THE GREATEST ESTATE DEVELOPER

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Chapter 311: The Compliment Linkage Effect (1)

“Actually, I can stop time!”

Lloyd dropped the bomb at the dinner table. He didn’t pull any punches. *What else was there to do, right?* He’s decided. Instead of beating around the bush, it would feel better to address this matter straightforwardly, considering the deep trust he had in the count and countess. This was the rationale behind his declaration. But there was something he overlooked, and it was that their trust in him was unimaginably deeper, heftier, and more incredible than he imagined.

“Honey.”

“Hmm?”

As soon as Lloyd spoke, Count Arcos and Countess Marbella started exchanging gazes with each other.

“It looks like our son has gone through a lot lately.”

“Hmm... Does it appear so to you as well?”

“Yes, my dear. He must be under an immense amount of stress to say something like that.”

“I feel the same way. Ha... I believe he is acting this way because of the expectations everyone has of him. He thinks he needs to make everyone happy and do something for them.”

“I am with you on that. The poor thing must have been struggling all by himself.”

“My heart is hurting. I think we have been too neglectful of our child.”

“We have been, my dear. It pains me to see him carry such a heavy burden all alone.”

“I wish we could help him in some way.”

“We should support him more at times like these, shouldn’t we?”

“Let’s lighten his stress a little first.”

“Yes, we should.”

The couple was on the same page. Tons of gazes were exchanged in this almost telepathic conversation, and they teamed up silently toward one goal: To alleviate their son’s stress. Count Arcos made the first move.

“Hmm, I see. That is amazing,” complimented Count Arcos ever so gently.

Lloyd looked at him with a dazed look. “You believed me so quickly?”

“I do. Have you ever lied to me before?”

“You are right. I never have.” Lloyd was glad that his words were well-received.

“Truly,” said Count Arcos, “I’m amazed at how hard you work every day. It takes a lot for a person to feel that they are frozen in time.”

“Eh...?” Lloyd lifted his brow, sensing that something was off.

“Honestly,” obliviously went on Count Arcos. “I, too, feel like I’m stuck in time sometimes. Very rarely, however. Lately, I mostly get that feeling when I give a hand to Marbella with her flower garden.”

“F-Flower garden?” muttered Lloyd.

The count smiled mysteriously. “Yes, her flower garden. As I crouch down under the strong sun with my hands covered in dirt, beads of sweat start dripping down my forehead. I can see the beautifully bloomed flowers while my stomach growls. Then I wonder to myself, “Oh, is it lunchtime now?”

“Ah... I don’t think-”

Count Arcos didn’t let Lloyd finish. “But when I stand up at that feeling and look up at the sky, I realize lunch is far yet to come. That is when I feel like I’m frozen in time.”

Lloyd pressed his lips.

“I wonder what it is with the gardening. I am truly mystified. So, at times __”

“Honey.” Count Marbella’s voice, which was ever so gentle, prompted Count Arcos to clamp his mouth upon belatedly realizing his mistake.

The smile on her face turned suggestive. “My, you told me you were happy when you helped me, but it appears that the work has taken a toll on your body.”

Count Arcos didn’t respond.

“What should I do now?” asked Count Marbella rhetorically. “I suppose I should work alone starting tomorrow.”

“No, no,” interjected Count Arcos hurriedly, “Honey, that is not what I meant—”

“What can I do?” Countess Marbella rubbed her nails. “The work makes you feel like you’re stuck in time. That is how dreadful the job is for you. I’m not going to force anyone to do something they hate.”

“I am happy!” cried out Count Arcos again. “Truly happy!”

“Do you mean that?” Count Marbella shot a meaningful gaze.

“Ehem...!”

“You should have told me if the work was that hard on you, my dear.”

“No, no, it is not hard on me... Ehem, it is just that sometimes I would like to ride my horse and enjoy the fresh breeze.”

“Then how about you take a break tomorrow and ride your horse?”

“M-me? Alone?”

“Yes.”

“Really?” Count Arcos’s face lit up.

“Yes, yes.”

“Th-Thank you, honey!”

“You are welcome.”

Staring at the overjoyed count and beaming countess, Lloyd heaved a sigh. “Um, it’s wonderful that you two love each other so much, but when I said that I can stop time-”

“It is all good,” Count Marbella interrupted softly, “I know what you mean. I am your mother.”

“Excuse me?” Lloyd asked.

“You do not have to think too hard. It’s okay to move forward one day at a time. Sometimes, failure is acceptable. Everything is all right, my son. You are doing very well already.”

“...”

“Stopping time?” She went on, “Changing the world? I do not expect such grand undertakings from you. You are my son, and that will never change no matter what you do. So, Lloyd.” She looked at Lloyd in the eyes.

“Yes.” Lloyd’s gaze met hers.

“Do not overwork yourself.”

“No, no, it’s not that.” Lloyd waved his hands.

“Shh.” Count Arcos put his finger on his lips to let Marbella finish. “You do not have to deny it.”

“I, too, have heard from your father,” Countess Marbella cast an appreciative look at Count Arcos. “How you did your utmost to stop the misfortune the Dragon King has enlightened you about. How you kept the matter and stress all to yourself because you were worried about us. How burdensome it must have all been for you, my Lloyd. How lonely.”

Lloyd slightly choked up, and he couldn’t say anything.

“The same is true now. Building a dam and a magnificent building called the Jewel... It must be difficult for you. I’m sure things will only get harder in the future. That is why I am saying this. You do not need to carry everything by yourself. If you are tired and struggling, tell us. We are your parents. Can you do that for us?”

“Um...” Lloyd gulped. “Yes.”

“All right, thank you, our dear son. Then should we go back to our meal? I rambled for too long. The food will get cold.”

Lloyd couldn’t refute their words or explain himself further, seeing their gentle smile. It wasn’t the time to press further. He couldn’t bring himself to erase the smile on the couple’s faces after hearing their words of encouragement and invigoration, which were spoken so carefully and considerately to him. At the same time, Lloyd felt wronged.

Argh... Please believe me, come on. I can really stop time!

How on earth am I supposed to make them understand me? Lloyd chewed and crunched salad as he smiled embarrassingly. The next day, however, something strange took place in the fiefdom. An incredible rumor spread across the place.

“Hey, did you hear? They say that Master Lloyd can stop time,” a woodcutter uttered to his brother.

“What?” The brother grimaced. “What are you talking about?”

“What do I mean? I heard it from my wife.”

“From your wife?”

“Yes.”

“Is she feeling all right?” asked the older brother skeptically.

“Oh, no,” he refused as he shook his head. “My wife overheard it from somewhere else too.”

“Somewhere else? Where?”

“From the servants in the lord’s manor.”

“What did they say?

“That Master Lloyd said he could stop time while having dinner with Count Arcos.”

“Haha, Really?”

The conversation between the woodcutter brothers took place under the tree shade. Soon, another conversation took place as well between a young shepherd and a young huntress in the meadow.

“Hey, did you know?” asked the boy as he tapped the ground with his staff.

“Know what?” brusquely asked the girl.

“Master Lloyd can stop time.”

“What?” She clucked her tongue as she shook her head. “You must have eaten something weird.”

“Nuh-uh. I’m telling the truth.”

She huffed annoyingly, “Where did you hear that nonsense?”

The boy crossed his arms. “From my sister.”

“Emily?” Her face softened.

“Uh-huh,” said the boy proudly.

“What did she say?”

“What the heck! You trust her but not me?”

“Obviously,” huffed the girl. “I’m not dumb enough to trust a liar like you.”

He gaped at her.

“Besides,” she went on, “If it’s coming from Emily, then it has to be true. So, tell me. What did she say?”

The boy pouted. “That Master Lloyd can stop time. He announced it while having dinner with Count Arcos.”

“And what was the lord’s reaction?”

“He laughed and comforted Master Lloyd. She said he looked pretty wronged.”

“Wronged?” she asked incredulously.

“Yes.”

“Then... It is true?”

“You agree?” exclaimed the boy delightfully. “Do you think so too? It doesn’t seem like nonsense, right?”

“Duh. It’s Master Lloyd. Right?”

“I think so, too!” The boy nodded.

At the same time, the bar owner raised his voice at his store.

“Oh, come on! What, did you think that Master Lloyd was that incapable?”

“Hey, old man, that’s not what I meant...”

The bar owner thrust his fist onto the desk. “Like heck, that wasn’t what you meant! It was all thanks to our young master that you have some land to farm on from the Maritz Wetland, isn’t that true? The rumor has it you did a fine job with your piece of land and sent your son to Cremo for school! So, how dare you question the young master’s capabilities!”

“Please,” the man reasoned pleadingly. “Don’t get worked up now-”

“How can I not?!” bawled the owner. “My young master is being questioned right now!”

“Come on, I said I believe it too!”

“You do?” At this, the bar owner’s voice softened.

“Yes, I do.”

“Then have a drink here,” he said as he poured a free drink. Then he said, “The thing is, I owe Master Lloyd a lot. You know about the ondol room he built outside the bar, right?”

“I know, yes.”

“My mother, you see, was able to be comfortable during her final days before she passed away, thanks to the ondol room. I’m still touched by his actions whenever I think of her. That’s why I’m doing this. If you see anyone questioning or insulting him, you know what to do.” The bar owner cracked his knuckles.

“My, I know. How could I not?”

“Anyway! He should be well enough to stop time! He sure is capable of doing such a thing! Yes, yes! Of course! I knew from the start that he was

going to be someone big! Yes!”

“But didn’t you used to wail every day about how he wreaks havoc at the bar?”

“The past is a past!”

The rumor spread through the mouths of the servants who were there at the dinner table. It was about how Lloyd could stop time. Everyone bought the rumor without hesitation. The atmosphere of trust hanging in the air was antithetical to what Lloyd had initially expected. And when the messages appeared in front of Lloyd’s eyes, he could clearly feel what was going on around him.

Ding Dong!

Hmm?

Lloyd opened his eyes wide. He was rolling around in bed as he struggled to fall asleep when a few messages popped in front of him.

[Rumors about you are spreading across the people of the fiefdom.]

[They completely believe your assertion that you can stop time and are growing excited about it.]

[Though dispassionate residents claim that it’s unrealistic, their opinions are being pushed aside by the general public.]

[The countless accomplishments and praises you’ve earned until now are allowing this kind of atmosphere to cultivate inside the fiefdom.]

[The title <Exemplifying Punisher> is at work.]

[The title <Builder of Dead Estates> is at work.]

[The title <Bell Saver> is at work.]

[The title <The Eldest Son of the Frontera Family> is at work.]

[The title <The Pathfinder to the Weary> is at work.]

[The title <Red Pill or Blue Pill> is at work.]

[The above six titles are bringing about a linkage effect.]

[The intimacy level with the fiefdom residents has increased from <Favor and Trust> to <Affection and Praise>.]

[From now on, the fiefdom’s residents will trust and support all your actions.]

What is this now?

Lloyd shook his head as he studied the messages in disbelief. Then he realized what they meant.

Wow!

The people believed in him. Not only that, they almost seemed to have blind faith in him as if they were his worshippers. Thanks to this, his Time Freeze skill was nothing strange to them.

I didn’t expect this at all.

Lloyd used to be strung out that they might consider him a dark magician for enabling something that goes against nature. He was afraid of losing their trust and receiving skeptical gazes. That was why he had chosen to discuss the matter with the count and countess first. His plan was to announce the Time Freeze skill to the people using the count’s authority to minimize the confusion and misunderstanding that may arise from his skill.

But I was worried for nothing. There won’t be any issues even if I use the time freeze right away.

Their trust in him went beyond his imagination. Lloyd smiled, the corners of his lips rising up to his ears. After all, the days he had spent busting his gut in this fiefdom weren’t all for nothing. Excited and overcome with a sense of reward, Lloyd couldn’t sleep at all. It was only after the sun began

to rise that he fell asleep. After breakfast, he waited for the sun to be up just enough. That was when Lloyd strolled out to the manor and stood in the front yard.

Now is the perfect time. Since the flow of time outside this area will come to a complete stop, the position of the sun won't change. So, sometime between nine and ten will work just fine.

Freezing time at night would be problematic as then it would always remain dark out. The afternoon wasn't a good time either since the scorching sun would make construction extremely difficult. As such, Lloyd picked the morning time when the sun was in the perfect position. He opened the optional skill window.

Ding dong.

[Manaheart Skill Option 5: Time Freeze - You can freeze time of this world by borrowing the power of the Heart of Winter in the manaheart.]

[Required RP to use the skill: 3,000]

[Current RP: 11,755]

[Would you like to use the Skill Option 5: Time Freeze?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a yes.

Lloyd chose "Yes."

Now, time to build the dam and the Jewel of Truth.

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At the same time, the heavenly world was completely unaffected by the frozen passage of time below. In the office of Gabriel the Seraphim, there came a scroll of an urgent report on his desk. The following statement was written outside it:

[Report of Illegal Construction Status on Earth: The Jewel of Truth Aotearoa]

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Chapter 312: The Compliment Linkage Effect (2)

“Hmm?” A frown line appeared between Gabriel’s elegant pair of brows. It was because of the bundle of reports on his office desk.

Illegal construction status report from the mundane world?

It had been eons ago since he received a report like this. 9,184 years, 9 months, and 28 days in the earth’s time to be exact.

I rarely receive a report like this.

It was because any building that necessitated this kind of report was not even permitted in the heavens and out of reach for the mundane world due to its extremely demanding construction requirements. Those down below would struggle to dare attempt such a construction.

Who dared to build something like this? Hmm. Let’s see.

Gabriel opened the report. The wrinkle between his brows deepened.

The Jewel of Truth. The Aotearoa.

The name was familiar. Gabriel searched through his memories.

I remember this building being demolished. It was too powerful and demanding for mundane creatures to handle. It even had the potential to reveal the deepest secrets of the upper realms. The demolition order for it eventually came through.

As a result, a terrible war broke out, and the Jewel of Truth was destroyed. Humans. Orcs. Elves. Merpeople. Giants, centaurs, and so many others. With the help of countless beings like them, the building was successfully demolished.

And someone is trying to build it again?

Gabriel couldn’t understand it. What kind of apt creature was conceived in the lower realm that was capable of erecting the illegal building? He perused the report that detailed how the building materials were gathered and where the construction was being done. He flipped through the pages with increasing speed to find the information he was looking for. At last, he found the name of the developer.

Lloyd Frontera.

Gabriel’s gaze was fixed on the name. He reached out and shook the bell on the desk. Not long after, someone entered his office.

“Raphael, the Director of Inspection for the lower realms. At your service.”

“Thanks for coming. I called you because I have a special assignment for you,” said Gabriel.

“Yes, please just give me the word.”

“It’s because of this.” Gabriel soon saw Raphael’s eyes grow serious as the latter skimmed through the report. “Your job is to put together a special surveillance team and watch Lloyd Frontera. I want you to give me a periodic report about the illegal construction he is carrying out.”

“Understood. But...” trailed off Raphael.

“What is it?”

“The Jewel of Truth is not just any kind of illegal building but the one that is at the top of its class that’s able to expose heaven’s secrets. Is it not better to stop the attempt early on instead of monitoring the situation from afar?” asked Raphael.

Gabriel chuckled. “You are right. Doing that would certainly be convenient. However, it’s not possible, and you know why.”

“Yes, I am aware,” Raphael said as he cast his head down. “We are not permitted to intervene in the mundane world’s affairs as heavenly beings.”

“You are right. Whatever happens down below is their business, not ours, in accordance with the way of things. That’s how it should remain to the most reasonable extent possible.”

“What do you mean, Your Grace?”

“The construction will be excruciatingly taxing, as the world will see a host of variables. An unfortunate accident may occur during construction. Otherwise, a design error may ruin their plans altogether. However, if that human overcomes these obstacles and gets close to completing the Jewel of Truth...”

“Then you will make an intervention?” asked Raphael hopefully.

“I should,” said Gabriel as he nodded. “It is an unlawful structure. At that time, I will order you to demolish it.”

“I see. Then I will form a surveillance team immediately.”

“Good. Keep up the good work.”

“Yes.”

Raphael left the room with a sharp salute distinct to the heavenly officials. Now alone at his office, Gabriel went over the report again. He then sighed midway.

“Dragon King Verkis... You raised hell this time again. I wonder what you were thinking when you told a mere human about the Jewel of Truth.”

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Meanwhile, in the Frontera fiefdom, Lloyd was completely ignorant of the special attention he was garnering from the archangel Gabriel. He was focused on the present moment for the sake of his peaceful retirement and using his Time Freeze skill while being showered with support from the fiefdom’s residents.

Ding Dong!

[Would you like to use the Skill Option 5: Time Freeze?]

[YES / NO]

Yes, yes, yes.

Lloyd happily selected YES. There was an immediate response.

[Manaheart Skill Option 5: Time Freeze has been activated.]

[You have spent 3,000 RP.]

[Current RP: 8,755]

[From now on, by the power of the Heart of Winter, the flow of time will remain frozen for one year. At this moment, you can designate a no-freeze zone where time flows normally.]

[The range of the no-freeze zone is determined by the total amount of mana you possess.]

[Current Range: 300km^2]

[Please assign the range of the no-freeze zone.]

According to the message before his nose, it looked like the range for the no-freeze zone could be as vast as half of Seoul city. Lloyd gave the answer he had determined in advance.

As large of a range as possible. But following the areas I outlined, not the shape of a circle.

As fiefdom as its center point, the no-freeze zone headed straight up north where the dam was to be erected and far into the east, covering the Prona River and areas around Lake Kapua. Lloyd wanted to make sure the fiefdom had a sufficient supply of drinking water while the Time Freeze skill was activated.

The river needs to keep flowing, and the waterway has to be operational.

Thankfully, that was possible within the amount of range he had.

Crackle...!

Ack!! Just like the last time, mana started to spill out of his manaheart like a strong tide. It almost felt like his esophagus and other organs were being yanked out of his body toward the heavens. The mana then turned into a gust of frigid air and shot toward the sky, forming a giant dome that was several miles tall. Soon, the passage of time outside the barrier came to a stop.

Ding dong.

[Time has been frozen.]

[The no-freeze zone cannot be changed until the optional skill is canceled.]

[The option is deactivated in the event the user goes out of the no-freeze zone.]

[Any creature within the range of the no-freeze zone will not age for a year.]

His view was filled with an onslaught of rewarding messages. Lloyd sucked in the breath he had been holding in.

Whoa. It worked.

Lloyd felt this time that the Time Freeze skill came with considerable side effects. It was as if all his strength had left his body. Despite that, the reaction from the residents made it all worth it.

“Mother,” asked a curious child, “What is that?”

“Yes, my dear son. That is the miracle shown to us by Master Lloyd.”

“Mother, what is a miracle?” the child asked again.

“Yes, my dear son. It is something Master Lloyd shows from time to time.”

“Mother, who is Master Lloyd?”

“Who else?” The mother said patiently, “He is our savior that you will serve in the future.”

The young lady gave the boy a big hug as she thought of the terrible fate that could have fallen on her child when the swarm of locusts invaded the land. Had it not for Master Lloyd’s zing, whew, what tragic fate awaited him! Master Lloyd was their lifesaver. As such, she had unshakable trust in her young master. Even though a strange wall was put up and the sun wasn’t moving, he must have a plan, she thought. Most of the residents had a similar reaction. They weren’t merely tolerating what was happening but enjoying the situation unfold.

“Hey, did you see that? What did I tell you? I was right!” exclaimed one of the woodcutter brothers.

“My goodness, you are right,” the older brother scratched his head embarrassingly. “Master Lloyd froze the sky. Does it mean that time has stopped outside? Outside the ice wall?”

“Yes, whereas we can move around like we always do. Wahaha!”

“But we are the only ones getting older.”

“Hush. You’re wrong. Did you forget who Master Lloyd is?” The young brother shot an incredulous look.

“Then what is it?”

“He said we won’t age.”

“While time is frozen?”

“Supposedly. Amazing, isn’t it?” He spoke with a smug on his face.

“Haha! Ha! If it is true, then we’re living longer for free!”

“That’s exactly right. A two-day celebration will be held to celebrate the occasion. Will you come?”

“Of course, I will be there. You don’t even need to ask.”

The woodcutter brothers excitedly went out of the house. A small festival had already begun in the central street. Everyone came to the festival wearing big smiles on their faces, joyous over the fact that they wouldn’t age and could go on with their lives normally, thanks to their young master who had stopped the flow of time. What a fantastic and exciting time it was to be alive, they thought. They gained an additional year of life filled with cheery mornings and sunlight for free. They merrily ate and drank, praising Lloyd for his amazing work. Even Count Arcos and Countess Marbella roamed through the streets and were content to hear the praises of their son. On the other hand, Lloyd put on a flustered smile as he watched the entire scene.

Wow. Look at these people. They’re no joke.

Lloyd had been concerned that he might be misunderstood. But he realized that it was the opposite. Instead of being misunderstood, he received loads of praise.

My, from the looks of it, they would’ve started booing me if I didn’t use the time freeze skill.

Seeing this, Lloyd contemplated whether he deserved their overflowing amount of trust and praise. Of course, the answer came naturally to him.

Of course, I deserve it all! I’ve done so many things for the people here!

Lloyd breathed heavily through his nose. He was the one who resuscitated the dying fiefdom, saved it from the Monster Domino incident, and raised the rural barony up to a county! As such, Lloyd decided to be more confident and brazen. When the festival came to an end, the dam construction ensued right away. The first step was to organize the laborers.

“Okay,” announced Lloyd aloud. “I’m sure you’ve heard already, but we are here today to hold up our shovels for the never-ending advancement of the fiefdom. Okay, Group One?”

“Dig! Carve! Scoop!”

Chop! Chop! Sir Bayern and the Engineering Corps took a step forward in unison at Lloyd’s calling. Their tanned skin and wrinkles around their eyes reflected their years of experience in the construction field. Whether they were in South Korea or here, they were sure to find work as supervisors.

“Engineers,” said Lloyd as he looked at them. “You are Group One for the joint project for the dam and Jewel of Truth. What’s Group One?”

“The center of the project!” Many among them shouted.

“Yes, indeed,” affirmed Lloyd with a nod. “I want you to think for a second here. Think of the time when you were new to shoveling. All the way back when you constructed the ondol with me.”

“...”

“You should never forget your resolution from then. And remember, nowhere is safe in the construction field. Accidents do not discriminate between newcomers and veterans. Keep that in mind and act as the center of the site. Regularly check in on your coworker’s work progress and set the right tone for the construction site. If you get it, then give me a chant.”

“Dig! Carve! Scoop!”

“Very well,” Lloyd said. “Next. Group Two?”

“Scoop! Transfer! Fill!

Lloyd turned. The White Cavalry. They were now addressed as the White Shovelers and held shovels and woven bags on their horsebacks. There was a time when they protested at the thought of holding a shovel. But now, everyone had evidently transformed into mobile shovelers. Lloyd’s gaze was filled with contentment.

“The White Cavalry. You will act as the lubricant for this project as it will require more dirt to be dug and transported than ever before. You are the greatest dirt transferrers I know. No one can move the heaps of soil better and more swiftly than you all. As such, why don’t you give me your chant as a promise to continue your good work this time as well?”

“Scoop! Transfer! Fill!” Their piercing chant rang aloud.

It was time for Group Three. But they didn’t have any chants and instead responded with the sound of clacking bones.

“Okay, Group Three?”

Clack!

The Skeleton Corps came forward with the sound of clacking bones. Since they couldn’t speak, they didn’t chant with their voice. Instead...

Raise! Raise! Raise! Turtle Neck, the leader of the group, Square Jaw, and Frozen Shoulder raised their pickets in order. The pickets had the Skeleton Corps’ chant written down on them...

[Overwork!]

[Burn the midnight oil!]

[Work until you die!]

Lloyd smiled with a glow of satisfaction.

“Good. You know it. You are tireless and strong. You don’t need any sleep or breaks. That is why I’m assigning you an important task. While Group One supervises the field and Group Two transfers the soil, you, Group Three, will be the main laborers working on the construction field. Therefore, I want to introduce you all to a new member.”

Clack?

The skeletons tilted their heads in confusion. Lloyd flashed a big smile and shouted, “Draggy! It’s time to greet your seniors!”

Boooom!

As soon as Lloyd finished, Draggy landed majestically and bowed at the skeletons. Every bone in its body shook in joy and overwhelming emotion. This was the moment it had been waiting for. It was finally enlisted in the Skeleton Corps. The skeleton members, too, jumped up and down at the news of a dependable newcomer joining them. They could proudly walk around with their chin held high now. They danced in sheer joy.

Just like that, a total of three groups were organized for the joint construction. One more group was added, and they were Javier and the fantastical creatures who would play the role of giant construction equipment. Then later, one more group, Group Five, was added, and it was composed of the blacksmiths, including Corgidus, and civilian volunteers. Its job mainly was providing support. When everything was good to go, the construction took off right away, starting with the foundation. The makeshift road was paved to allow the transfer of materials. Limestones and rocks were collected. Bangul produced volcanic ash for concretes. Each group had different tasks, and everything progressed smoothly.

One day, however, a telepathic message came to Lloyd out of the blue.

“You over there, my beneficiary. There’s a huge problem. You better hurry up here if you want to continue building the Jewel of Truth. Now.”

The telepathic message was from Dragon King Verkis. His voice sounded urgent.

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Chapter 313: Swordmaster Syndrome (1)

“You over there, my beneficiary. There’s a huge problem. You better hurry up here if you want to continue building the Jewel of Truth. Now.”

Hmm?

Under the sun, Lloyd winced at the piercing voice that interrupted him while he was managing the construction site.

“Dragon King Verkis?” replied Lloyd.

“Yes, it’s me. You know where I am. Run over here within one second. Pronto.”

What could it be? The frown on Lloyd’s face deepened. He was confused about what was happening.

What does that sleepyhead need from me?

What terrified Lloyd more was the fact that the Dragon King woke up by himself. How serious could this possibly be?

I’ve never woken him up since I activated the Time Freeze skill.

As time had stopped flowing outside the fiefdom, Lloyd didn’t need to wake Verkis up in the morning. Verkis, too, had happily exclaimed, “Okay, I can freely sleep now?” and went straight into slumber.

Yet, he just woke up by himself. And he’s calling for me while saying that something terrible has happened. I’ve got a bad feeling about this.

Something had happened without a doubt. Something grave and dangerous, given the fuss this lazy dragon was throwing.

“Sir Bayern,” called Lloyd. “I need to go somewhere. Watch over the site for me.”

After entrusting the job to Sir Bayern, Lloyd rushed to the guest's chamber.

"Ha... Is something wrong?" Lloyd barged in on the room without knocking first. And then, he saw.

"Ah, there you are."

The Dragon King was lying in bed, but there was something awkward about his posture. To be exact, his neck was tilted in an unnatural angle. Wiping the sweat off his forehead, Lloyd asked, "I came running right away since you said it was trouble. Am I late? Did something happen?"

"Yes, something did," replied Verkis gravely. "But you're not late, thankfully. Here's what happened."

Lying flat on the bed, Verkis rolled his eyes to point his neck. He didn't even lift a finger.

And then he said in a cheerful voice, "I have muscle cramps."

"Come again?" Lloyd gawped.

"I have muscle cramps."

"..."

"This is bad," Verkis went. "I can't believe I have muscle cramps just from sleeping in the same position for a mere month. My body isn't the same anymore. Ha. I miss my younger days. I used to sleep for 500 years straight and not even feel an itch, let alone a cramp."

Lloyd didn't respond.

"Anyway, that's why I called you."

"Um..." Lloyd swallowed. "You see..."

"Okay, do speak now."

“So, you rushed to call me because you got a stiff neck while sleeping?”

“Yes.”

“…”

“Why? Is it not a big deal?” Verkis asked cheerfully.

No, it’s not!

Lloyd screamed but only inwardly. And if only he could, he wanted to jump and lay a double kick to the dragon’s gut.

I’m already slammed with work as it is!

It was true. He was really busy at the moment. There were countless elements to be taken into account to ensure the success of the construction of the dam and the Jewel of the Truth. He couldn’t take his eyes off the construction site. Taking a break was a luxury he couldn’t afford. He couldn’t even think of resting even after all the laborers left as he had to help wrap up the construction site at the end of the day. This meant staying alone at the site, inspecting the work that was done, checking over safety measures, and preparing necessary work materials and equipment for the following day. He wasn’t exaggerating when he said he had no time for rest. He barely had time to sleep or eat!

And as I’m working myself to death, the Dragon King urgently summoned me over a few cramps? Ugh, this bastard!

Lloyd yearned to grab the dragon by his collar and aggressively shake him. The violent impulse surged in him like a plant blooming in a green meadow. But instead of giving in to his emotions, Lloyd controlled himself and put on a smile.

“Certainly,” Lloyd groveled by force, “It is a big deal. It really is. Now, what can I do for you?”

Lloyd repressed all the murderous desire he had from seeping into his eyes and put on a big smile, transforming himself into a polite salesman.

But Dragon King Verkis was brazen and shameless. “Give me a massage.”

Lloyd stopped. “Excuse me?”

“Here.” Dragon King Verkis pointed at his neck with his gaze.

A few strands of hair rose at the back of Lloyd’s head. “Um, excuse me, Dragon King Verkis.”

“Yeah?”

“Isn’t it more convenient if you use your healing magic instead of getting a massage?” Lloyd stressed.

“Oh, that?” drawled Verkis. “That’s too much work.”

“...”

“I need to use my brain for that. But if I call you, I won’t have to do any of that. Much more convenient for me.”

“...”

“Okay. Start the massage.”

“Understood...”

Why are my eyes getting wet? But it was rage and anger that prompted such emotions. Lloyd grabbed the neck of the Dragon King.

Haah. I want to strangle him just like this.

Lloyd put his emotions into his hands and used all the strength he had to press down. Gripping the back of Verkis, his anticipation grew.

He’s going to end up screaming in pain for sure. My grip is quite strong with all the shoveling and construction work I do. This is going to hurt quite a bit for him. Kekeke!

And the moment the Dragon King groaned, Lloyd would feign surprise and put on an apologetic look and control his strength then. This petty idea for revenge pleased Lloyd. But his plan didn't go as he imagined. *Crack!*

Hmm? Lloyd stopped. *I can't get my hands in. Why?*

Even though his grip had enough force, his fingers failed to press into the dragon's skin. It felt like he was grabbing a rock. No, a chunk of titanium.

Why is this so hard?

Lloyd was flustered. The muscles under his skin were worse. Without exaggeration, it seemed that any sword would break in half before it even cut into his skin.

Is it because he's the Dragon King? How's he so sturdy and powerful even in his human form?

Lloyd felt dumbstruck. Then came another blow that contributed to his dismay - a scolding from the Dragon King.

"Come on. Do it properly!" demanded Verkis impatiently.

"Excuse me?" Lloyd's tone rose a little.

"I thought you were going to massage me."

"Um, I'm trying my best."

"No, you're not," huffed Verkis in an annoyed voice. "Not in the slightest. I don't feel a thing."

"..."

"Are you half-assing this on purpose because you're annoyed that I called you out in the middle of work? Are you taking your grudge out on me? Wow... I'm seeing a completely different side of you. I didn't know this was the kind of person you were. Had I known, I'd have never given you my help."

“...”

“Right. Humans are always like this. They don’t know how to be grateful. I gave you aid, sent you to another dimension to find the key materials for the Jewel of Truth, and even personally came to your fiefdom to sleep. And yet, when I call you for help, what do you do? You wrinkle your face in grimace and won’t even use any strength to massage me out of spite.”

“...”

“What, do you want me to get upset and cancel your sponsorship now?”

The warning knocked sense into Lloyd at once. “I will try harder!”

Crud! Crud! Crud!

Lloyd tightened his grip, almost crying inside. But it was far from enough to dig into the dragon’s skin.

Okay, my physical strength isn’t enough.

Ziiing! As such, Lloyd activated the Asrahan Core Technique, formed a three-strand circle, and activated it at full force. He then extracted mana from his manaheart, amplified it, and brought it back to his manaheart again. The manaheart sent explosive strength to his arms and hands. At last, the effect started to show.

I did it! I’m getting in!

Ever so slightly, his fingertips began to press into the back of the Dragon King’s neck skin. At first, it went in by a tenth of an inch. And then, it tripled. And some more until the facial expression on the Dragon King softened.

“Ugh, that tickles. You can do it!” encouraged Verkis heartily.

“Arggh! Argh! I will... My Lord!”

Massaging tense muscles was hard, but that would only be the case in the beginning. Once the knots loosened up, the muscle would soften, Lloyd thought. He buckled down and got to his task at hand.

You've got to be kidding me! Arggh!

Lloyd had never massaged anyone with this much devotion, not even his father in South Korea. A sense of shame started to bloom in him as he put in more effort to press down. His back began to become soaked in sweat. Lloyd painstakingly gave the king a neck massage for a seemingly endless period of time. As he did, a question came from the Dragon King.

"By the way, what do you plan on doing after building the Jewel of Truth?"

"Eek! Whew! What was that?" Lloyd wiped the sweat off his face.

"The Jewel of Truth. What do you plan on doing with it afterward?" Verkis spoke casually again.

"What do you mean what will I do? I'm going to ask how I can stop the restoration of destiny."

"Yeah, I know that part," Verkis retorted cynically. "I mean, after you go through all the steps to stop it. What will you do with the Jewel of Truth?"

Lloyd was speechless, not because he had nothing to say. It had finally dawned on him.

This is why he called me. It was to ask me this question.

At last, Lloyd understood. The muscle cramps and whatnot. It was nothing but a pretense.

Is he worried that I might misuse it?

Lloyd assumed so, and he was right. Dragon King Verkis was indeed worried about that possibility.

It never occurred to me that this human would build the Jewel of Truth.

Dragon King Verkis cast a remorseful gaze at his pillows as he lay down on his belly. In all honesty, he never knew that Lloyd would find the lot for the Jewel of Truth and find all the key materials for it scattered around the world. This was something Verkis had never even fathomed could happen.

It would be impossible for a dragon to accomplish such a thing, let alone a human. That's why I casually told him about it. The possibility of him finding all the materials for the jewel never crossed my mind. I didn't know the situation would get this serious or that the jewel would actually get built again.

But it was all coming true. That was why he was concerned.

What if he gets greedy after the jewel is constructed? What if he abuses its power?

What will happen then? What kind of evil will he do to the world? And what will I need to do then? These questions pestered Verkis.

Anyway, since I'm the one who taught Lloyd about the jewel, I'm responsible if he does something unnecessary and brings harm to the world.

Verkis thought he should take the fault if that happened. As such, he wanted to hear what Lloyd's plan was. The human would obviously get greedy over the Jewel, and the dragon wanted to know how he'd mask it. If Verkis sensed any perverted desire in Lloyd...

I'll destroy the silly thing then.

He would grind it into dust. That way no one would ever build it again. Thinking so, Verkis waited for Lloyd's answer. And eventually...

"Um... I..." Lloyd finally spoke. "I find the jewel to be quite burdensome, honestly."

"What?"

What a weak and shameless mask to cover his greed, Verkis thought as he frowned.

“Really,” Lloyd continued to speak. “To me, I feel that having high aspirations becomes a burden more than anything.”

“A burden? Why?”

“The thing is, I have led a life of struggle.”

“Struggle?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded. Now, his excited voice has calmed down, as if he was pouring his heart out. “I used to get nosebleeds every day. I had to get to work as soon as I opened my eyes in the early morning, sweating throughout the day even though I didn’t want to. Even when I was exhausted, I had to push myself to work. Amidst all that, I still had to study because of my future aspirations.”

“What was it?”

“To start an ordinary family,” casually said Lloyd.

“In the world you came from?”

“Yes. It’s just... All I wanted was a proper family that would greet me after I came home from work. With them, I thought it would be nice to live an ordinary and happy life with the money I make.”

“So?”

“So, I worked hard every day. That is, before I found myself here. But my dream hasn’t changed even after I got here.”

“To start a family?”

“Yes, though I’ve come to covet one more thing,” confessed Lloyd.

“What’s that?”

“Lazing around for the rest of my life.”

“Ohh?” Verkis sounded intrigued.

“Now that I have a prosperous life in this fiefdom, I want to protect it and enjoy everything that it offers. And now, I want to stay here and laze around for the rest of my life. With my family, I have come to yearn for the relaxed life of a retiree. And that is why....”

Lloyd meant every word he said, and his voice now contained force.

“It will be just burdensome for me to obtain more power, larger territories, a stronger military, or something along that line. I’ll be kept away from leisure to deal with it all. Doesn’t it seem like a lot of work? Thus, my only wish is for my family and the people around me to be at ease and happy. I want to live the rest of my life surrounded by their warmth without another day of work.”

“And that is why the Jewel of Truth is a burden to you?”

“Yes, since I already have everything necessary to make my dream come true. Nothing more is needed. So long I stop the restoration of destiny, I’ll be able to achieve my goal. Anything beyond that would just become a stumbling block to my dream.”

“...”

“So,” went on Lloyd. “I don’t plan to use the Jewel of Truth after stopping my destiny unless things get seriously dire. That’s my plan. Since I wish to lead a happy and relaxed life as a bum.”

“...”

“My king?”

“What?” blurted Verkis.

“Why are your eyes wet?”

“I’m touched.”

“What...” Lloyd was astonished. Verkis was serious.

Ha. I was wrong. This kid is a wannabe bum, just like me.

Lloyd's speech tugged at Dragon King Verkis's heartstrings, and this new profound realization rang in his heart. He could instantly recognize what Lloyd was. This human was a wannabe bum. Verkis knew this because he, too, was a master bum. Lloyd turned out to be a boy with modest aspirations for life. The desire to not work for life! The greed to be relaxed all the while! The attitude of the rich landlord who led the life of an unemployed bum! Due to his chronic laziness, he could see Lloyd’s desire and genuineness.

“Stop.” Verkis stopped Lloyd’s massage. And he started at him, slightly touched. “Thanks for baring your heart. I understand. Good luck with your goal.”

“T-Thank you.”

Dragon King Verkis decided. He wouldn’t destroy the Jewel of Truth. He would just watch over the construction process. Just like that, he accepted Lloyd’s dreams and aspirations. At that exact moment, the result of fully harnessing his manaheart and circle while massaging the Dragon King appeared in front of Lloyd’s eyes.

Ding dong.

With an unexpected alarm sound...

[You have pushed your manaheart to its maximum capacity.]

[As a result, you have earned experience points.]

[The new experience points are being added to your current inventory of experience points.]

[Skill Class Level Up!]

[Skill Name: Manaheart.]

[Stage: High-Level Sword Expert Lv. 1]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 1,500%]

[Currently Owned Optional Skills: 1. Shock Neutralizer / 2. Complete Resistance to Poison / 3. Frenzy / 4. Half-Human Half-Dragon / 5. Time Freeze]

[Required RP to level up: 2,000]

[Your Manaheart skill level has risen to the rank of <High-Level Sword Expert>.]

Eh...? Lloyd's eyes widened at the unexpected message.

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Chapter 314: Swordmaster Syndrome (2)

[Skill Class Level Up!]

[Your Manaheart skill level has risen to the rank of <High-Level Sword Expert>.]

Eh...?

Lloyd's eyes widened at the unexpected message.

What is this? What the heck?

Lloyd was lost for words, and more so as he never expected this turn of events. But more messages continued to appear one after, unaware of Lloyd's astonishment.

Ding Dong!

[Your manaheart has gone through countless events thus far. However, you have intentionally limited its activity as of recently. But today, you have loosened your restraint and employed its powers in full force.]

[In the process, the small amount of experience points you earned created a ripple effect.]

[You have finally achieved the extraordinary feat of becoming a high-level sword expert.]

[For this special experience, you have been awarded with a new optional skill.]

[Skill Option 5: Swordmaster Syndrome - All your senses will be heightened to an extreme level. This hyper-sensitivity of your senses is close to that of a fully developed swordmaster. This optional skill is activated for 24 hours a day and cannot be shut off.]

[Current RP: 8,755]

Whaat?

Lloyd was shell-shocked. Once when he read the messages. Then again when his heightened senses overwhelmed him.

“Hey! What’s wrong?”

WHAT’S WRONG? WHAT’S WRONG? WHAT’S WRONG?

Ack!

Lloyd frantically covered his ears at the booming voice of Dragon King Verkis that was supposed to sound normal.

Wh-What the heck?!

Lloyd gulped in sheer dismay. And this time, another noise assaulted him: The sound of saliva sliding down his throat came like a clap of thunder. Furthermore, he could even feel the saliva slide down every cell in his throat!

What’s going on...

Lloyd rolled his eyes and sharply felt that movement as well. Shaking up terribly, Lloyd stared at Verkis.

Since when was this world so vivid? Or is there something wrong with my eyes? My sight is just... How did I see things back then?

Verkis appeared so vividly in front of him that Lloyd could even see the pores on the former’s cheeks. He could probably give a high-five to the mites living inside his skin. Simply put, his eyesight had drastically improved to the point of it being excessive.

Ugh. Hold on. Hold on a second!

A pang of dizziness suddenly hit him, and his feet ached. He had never felt this way before. The sensation of his weight pressing down his two feet felt overwhelming.

“Hey!” called out Verkis. “Are you okay?”

YOU OKAY?! YOU OKAY?! YOU OKAY?!

Ack!

Lloyd was afraid that his ears might burst. Collecting himself, he managed to say, “I am all right...”

“Then what’s with you all of a sudden?”

“Um, the thing is... I think I’ve become a sword expert...”

“Expert?”

“High-level,” muttered Lloyd in agony.

“What? Just now? You?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd managed to nod, which gave him another pang of shock because of the movement in his neck muscles and bones. But it looked like Dragon King Verkis was completely unaware of or disinterested in Lloyd’s pain and disquietude.

“Oh, really?” congratulated Dragon King Verkis nonchalantly. “Good for you.”

This is all because of you, you lazy dragon! Lloyd smothered the burning rage inside him. Then he began to somewhat grasp what had happened to him.

So, this is the swordmaster syndrome...

The message from a while ago informed him that he had become a high-level sword expert and was equipped with a new optional skill. Swordmaster syndrome.

Unbelievable. Lloyd was flustered by the hyper-sensitivity of his senses. Barely suppressing his dizziness, he struggled to adjust to his excessively heightened senses.

Wait, does this mean that Javier has been enduring all of this?

Lloyd pictured Javier from his past memories. From the moment he first met to the queen's assassination attempt. It was only now that Lloyd fully recognized the monstrous ability of the knight.

Haah. No wonder he has insomnia.

So, this was why Javier couldn't sleep. Heck, Lloyd even wondered if it was possible to carry on his daily life.

Javier and Scheherazade. Sir Blanc of the White Cavalry. They endured this kind of condition like it was nothing and never missed a single training for swordfighting?

Lloyd used to be nonchalant about this fact, but now that he suffered from the swordmaster syndrome, it became clear to him how impressive they were. More than just impressed, he respected them.

Ah... This is exactly the reason why I put a lot of effort into not becoming a high-level sword expert.

The swordmaster syndrome was a great obstacle any high-level sword expert faced. It was the final challenge that came before becoming a glorious swordmaster. Lloyd, to be honest, didn't wish for any of it. Not a single iota of his heart desired to become a swordmaster. There was no need for it, and that was the same now.

"Well then, I will be going now... Ack," groaned Lloyd.

"Sure, no problem."

Lloyd staggered out of the room after a brief greeting. An impulse to lay a punch to the dragon's face interrupted him on his way out. But he managed

to suppress it and walked out to the corridor. When he came outside, his senses became with the chaos outside.

CHIRP! CHIRP! CHIRP! CHIRP!

SWISH! SWISH! SWISH!

FWOOSH! FWOOSH! FWOOSH!

Lloyd didn’t realize how many birds his fiefdom had until then. And the drifting breeze! It sounded like a storm. The grass frantically banged sideways against the wind. Amid the unfamiliar and new stimulations around him, Lloyd thought to himself...

This won’t do. No.

He decided that he couldn’t live like this. Impulsively, he opened the system window and checked his RP.

[Current RP: 8,755]

He didn’t have enough. It wasn’t even close. He thought he had accumulated quite a bit of RP. But that turned out to be untrue.

I’ll need at least 2,000 RP more just to level up my manaheart skill. That’s why this isn’t enough.

Lloyd rashly wondered if he could earn enough RP with his construction work to becoming a swordmaster. But he quickly shook his head.

No. That would be impossible.

Lloyd reiterated several times in his head that he couldn’t give in to his impulsive thoughts.

Sure, if I work hard to earn more RP, I might be successful. But what about the dam and the Jewel of Truth? The construction of the dam and the Jewel of Truth will take a few months to a year to complete. That will be the case

without a doubt if things for according to plan. What about after the jewel is constructed? Who knows. I might find myself needing a lot of RP.

Such a thought crossed his mind. He was only a few months away before constructing the Jewel of Truth and asking for a solution to stop the restoration of destiny.

I can't even predict what answer it'll give. What if... the jewel demands a large sum of RP to answer my question?

Yet, if he had no RP left after spending it all to level up his manaheart to the level of a swordmaster and overcome his swordmaster syndrome?

That would be the end of everything.

This sort of disastrous and laughable situation seemed possible wherein he couldn't ask the question to the Jewel of Truth because he had used all his RP.

Of course, I might not need any RP to ask the jewel a question. But life is full of surprises. I don't know what's ahead of me... So, I should endure for a few months.

Upon consideration, it was obvious what course of action he should take. Even though he hated to admit it, there was nothing else he could do.

I can adjust to my heightened senses and bear through my insomnia for a bit. It'll only be a few months at most. During that time, I can quickly build the dam and the Jewel of Truth and then learn how to stop the restoration of destiny.

That should do it. If the solution did not require him to use his RP, he could easily buckle down and earn more until he became a swordmaster. That was the safest course of action he could take at this point in time.

Haah. But seriously, this is terrible.

Lloyd sucked in his breath in determination. In all seriousness, this situation was truly terrible. He had merely taken a few steps, but every sensation he

felt was devastatingly overwhelming. As he moved forward, the sensation of the rays of sunlight against his skin as well as the weight of his steps, were painfully vivid. His head constantly ached from the sensations he felt. But he continued to walk, telling himself he'd adjust and adapt to the change. It would be similar to when he learned how to walk when he was a child. Every step he took was slow, careful, and measured.

Just like that, he strove to get used to the drastic changes in his senses. It wasn't easy. But eventually, by the time he arrived at the construction site, he managed to considerably recover from his nausea. However, it wasn't enough to fool Javier's sharp senses.

"Master Lloyd," called Javier.

"Yeah?"

"Are you all right?" asked Javier, studying the length of Lloyd from head to toe.

"Could it be..." Lloyd frowned. "You noticed?"

"Yes. Congratulations, Master Lloyd."

"Tsk. I don't know."

Javier was Javier. Lloyd had believed that he did a good job of not showing any signs of his change to Javier. But in less than three minutes of Lloyd's arrival, Javier sent a knowing gaze toward him, which indicated that he realized what happened.

Feeling the strong desire to clap his ears because of Javier's voice, the nearby shouting, and shoveling noises around him, Lloyd spoke, "Is how it's like for everyone else?"

"If you are inquiring about the swordmaster syndrome, yes. That is how it is."

"How did you cope with this?" groaned Lloyd.

“I regarded it as a form of training to gain control over my senses.”

“Training?”

“Yes,” affirmed Javier. “Train to flatten the sharpness of my senses, accept them as they are, and take the reins on them. I wanted to keep them at a level where my senses wouldn’t cause any disturbance but wouldn’t miss anything happening around me. I considered it as a key part of my path to becoming a swordmaster.”

“Argh...”

“What is wrong?” replied Javier with a soft smug on his face.

“Um, please, could you keep your words short?”

Javier crossed his arms. “Do you feel dizzy when someone speaks at length?”

“Yeah.” Lloyd pressed his temple. “It makes me feel sick.”

“Hmm,” observed Javier, “I suppose you have not reached the stage of being able to filter your auditory senses. Well, that only makes sense, given that you have just been inflicted with swordmaster syndrome. It was the same for me too. This conversation takes me back to my first day of having swordmaster syndrome. At that time, in the training hall-”

“Hey,” Lloyd said in an annoyed voice.

“Yes, Young Master.”

“You’re doing this on purpose, aren’t you?” Lloyd shot a look at Javier.

“Do what?”

“You’re doing it on purpose because I told you to speak less.”

“That’s right.” Javier gently lifted his brow.

“Wow. You won’t even deny my accusation.”

“This will all be nothing but beneficial for you later on.”

“Are you sure it’s not for your personal revenge and satisfaction?”

Javier suppressed his smile. “Not at all.”

“I’m right.”

“So, on the first night I experienced my swordmaster syndrome-”

“You’re not listening to me at all,” interrupted Lloyd again. “I do not have to listen to you. Anyway, on that first night, I thought that the hardship that came from my senses would nurture my growth. I believe I would become a proud swordmaster the day I overcame these hardships. So, even when a storm of sensations shook me up and pierced through my entire body like thousands of thorns, I did not give up.” Lloyd’s words, however, fell on deaf ears. “Can you please stop talking...?” Lloyd was almost begging by now.

“I cannot. This is truly a rare opportunity.”

“For you to harass me?”

“Who do you think I am?” huffed Javier as if he didn’t like being falsely accused. “I am sharing how my fierce efforts allowed me to overcome my swordmaster syndrome.”

“Oh, sure, sure,” drawled Lloyd, “I’m sure you are. Damn it.”

“By the way, why are you crying?” inquired Javier.

“Do you need to ask?”

“Personally, I never cried,” remarked Javier proudly. “And I did not miss a single day of training. Although, I eventually fell for your trick in the end.”

“Hold on,” Lloyd raised his finger. “What do you mean? What trick of mine?”

“Your lullaby, Young Master.”

“I thought you liked it. You said it was satisfactory.”

“Yes, but it had an addictive effect on me similar to a drug.”

“Aha,” remarked Lloyd. “You were happy on the outside, but deep down, you developed a grudge?”

“Speaking of, do you need my help?”

“Help? For what?”

“Won’t you have to overcome this?”

“Tsk. I should.” Lloyd grimaced. His ears loudly buzzed as he conversed with Javier, and it was making him lose his mind. The strange thing, however, was that his ears started to feel better throughout the conversation.

It’s almost like I’m undergoing an intense training.

Or as if he was being forced to adjust.

Whatever it is, I can’t continue on like this.

Lloyd figured that he had to overcome it one way or another. Otherwise, his everyday life would be affected. No, it would also impact his construction projects. Still, he obviously couldn’t use all his RP.

I have to make an effort.

This marked the beginning of Lloyd’s special training to overcome his swordmaster syndrome.

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Chapter 315: Swordmaster Syndrome (3)

Swordmaster syndrome. A formidable obstacle every knight confronted before completely mastering their swordsmanship. Since the Lorasian Continent's inception, countless creatures across all races had experienced this syndrome. Hotheaded orc warriors, courageous merpeople, cold-hearted elf archers. The swordmaster syndrome pestered them as soon they reached the level of a high-level sword expert. Despite the continent's long history, only about 300 individuals overcame it.

Haa... In other words, there were many who failed to overcome it. I wonder what the exact number is. I'm guessing it's easily in the tens of thousands.

Lloyd was seated on the sofa. When he sighed, the sensation in his nostrils sent him into a state of shock. The wind passing through his nostrils felt too strong, and it caused the fine hairs inside him to clearly sway against his skin. Lloyd shuddered at the strange feeling.

I hate this syndrome!

Three days had passed already, but he still wasn't used to it. He worried whether he would ever get used to this. Before he knew it, dark circles appeared under his eyes.

I'm tired.

But sleeping was impossible with all the noise around him. Even when his surroundings were quiet and the window was tightly shut, the wind blowing outside sounded like a violent storm in his ears. And when he shoved his head into a pillow and clapped his ears shut, the pulse in his veins boomed like a beating drum.

So, I'm an insomniac now thanks to the swordmaster syndrome. This is nuts, really. Lloyd heaved a sigh. Just then, he heard the thunderous voice of Javier.

"You should not lose focus now. Please concentrate, Young Master."

“Ugh, you surprised me...” Lloyd frowned.

“Does my voice still sound too loud?”

“Obviously,” huffed Lloyd. “If you are going to speak, can’t you give me a sign before you do?”

“I cannot,” rejected Javier coldly.

“Why not?”

“Because that would not provide any training or allow you to adjust to your senses.”

“Come on. So, what, you want me to stay on the sofa and keep my eyes closed all day long like this?” Lloyd closed his eyes.

“You are practicing how to maintain this state of silence.” Javier’s voice sounded like that of a teacher.

“What does this change?”

Instead of answering the question, Javier instructed, “Throw yourself into the silence. Confront the sharp tail end of your heightened senses. Focus on where that sharpness is pointing. Embrace it. Tolerate it. Accept it. Only then will you be able to find genuine peace inside yourself.”

“Fine,” droned Lloyd, “I get it, Monk Javier Asrahan.”

“Monk?” retorted Javier in confusion. “What is that?”

Lloyd shrugged, still closing his eyes. “Something I heard when I was in Seoul.”

“What did you hear?”

Lloyd said, “There are people who are called monks in that world. I heard the others talk on my way from the bathroom.”

“And so, are you saying I resemble those people called monks?”

“Yeah. They love to use esoteric jargon, and you fit the bill.”

“...”

“In other words, I don’t get a clue as to what you mean,” Lloyd protested, shaking his head. “Sharp tail end of my senses? What in the world are you talking about?”

“Pay attention to your inner self,” replied Javier patiently, “And you will naturally feel what it is.”

“I am already paying attention right now,” Lloyd stressed every word to drive his point home.

However, Javier was unimpressed. “It does not look like it, Master Lloyd.”

Lloyd sighed. “I’m trying.”

“It’s still not enough.”

“Ack! Ack! Dammit!” yelled Lloyd as he suddenly tapped the arms of the sofa with his palms.

To this, Javier could only say, “Calm the rage inside you and find peace. Now, breathe.”

Lloyd obeyed. “Whew...”

“There you go,” cooed Javier. “Good boy.”

“Hey.” Lloyd opened his eyes.

“Focus, Young Master.”

Lloyd was about to fall into a rage the longer he thought about the situation, but there wasn’t anything he could do. Javier was the one with experience, living proof that he could completely overcome his syndrome. As such,

Lloyd could only follow Javier’s instructions, believing he would gain guidance on how to deal with his senses more efficiently.

From that day onward, Lloyd left the construction field to Sir Bayern and was engrossed in his quasi-meditation sessions on the sofa of his bedroom. He used the time to further familiarize himself with his sharpened senses. The effect of this was immense.

Wow. Wow... This is working.

Two days in, Javier’s voice diminished from being comparable to the sound of thunder to mere desk tapping. The sensation of saliva sliding down Lloyd’s throat and hair swaying in his nostrils had reduced considerably as well.

I guess Javier is still useful in one way or another.

As expected, Javier’s teachings were effective. From that moment on, Lloyd focused entirely on meditating. Three days passed. Then five days passed. At last, on the fifteenth day, Lloyd managed to suppress his heightened senses just enough to continue his daily life.

“Ha...” Lloyd inhaled and looked around.

His nausea was now reduced to a noticeable degree. It turned out that spending every minute of his day in meditation wasn’t a waste after all. However, there was still one hurdle left for him to cross.

“Okay, does this mean my insomnia is cured?” asked Lloyd.

“You shouldn’t get your hopes up, Young Master.”

Javier’s answer disappointed Lloyd. “Is that so...”

“Yes,” replied Javier cold-heartedly. “Even I could not overcome insomnia before your lullaby.”

“Okay, then how about we do this?”

A sudden idea popped into his head as he conversed with Javier.

Then, I'll listen to a lullaby, too!

Lloyd immediately brought out a piece of paper and pen, remembering what he had studied back in his college years. He then quickly scribbled down lesson content from some of his major-related courses.

So, this and that, bla bla... Here and that... Okay.

After a short wrestle with his memory, Lloyd was able to fill the entire page.

"Hey, read this for me," demanded Lloyd as he held out a paper.

"Excuse me?"

"Read it. This one," urged Lloyd again.

"Wait. Is this a lullaby for yourself?"

"Yeah. Can you read it? It's nothing too complicated. I made sure to avoid any difficult language, so it's easy to read. You just need to read through it without stuttering."

"..."

"Okay, come on."

Lloyd jumped onto the bed and covered himself with a blanket. He then sent an expectant gaze to Javier. Come on now. I can sleep now. I am a genius for devising this plan. Praising himself inwardly, Lloyd looked forward to sleeping well after fifteen days of insomnia. At last, Javier began to recite the lullaby.

"Hah. I see. Then, hmm... The Limit State Design method attempts to deal with the stability of the structure probabilistically by considering the load action and fluctuations of the material strength... Blah blah... Based on the

mechanical behavior of the material... Whatnot... It is regarded as being displayed as it is in the completed structural system."

“Good. Keep going,” Lloyd urged.

A wide grin hung on Lloyd’s face. To his relief, Javier was reciting the lullaby without much stuttering. Lloyd’s anticipation grew. He closed his eyes, recalled his college days, imagined Javier’s voice to be that of a boring professor, and tried to fall into a state of happy slumber.

“However, no matter how much attention is paid to the quality control of materials, the proposed value in the design... This and that... In the application of loads, the load given in the specification is... Blah blah... Probabilistic considerations will ensure that the stability of the structure is properly assessed.”

“Okay, more. Keep going.”

Let’s go to sleep. Please let me fall asleep. I can do it! I can go fall asleep! So, continue! The corners of his eyes trembled. He engineered his brain to make Javier’s voice sound boring.

"In general, when designing a structure, the allowable stress design method using the safety factor concept has a small working load... Um... If sagging or cracking is not a problem… a bill... Development of structure interpretation and design capabilities...um... High-strength rebar and...phew...the ingredients... *Zzz*...”

“Hey?” Lloyd opened his eyes when Javier’s recitation stopped. Then, he saw.

“Are you asleep?” asked Lloyd.

Snore... Javier didn’t answer.

“I asked if you’re sleeping,” repeated Lloyd.

Phew...

“Hey,” begged Lloyd. “Hello? Professor?”

“Phew...”

Lloyd teared up. How was he to accept this situation wherein his attempt to make himself fall asleep with the textbook recitation made the reciter fall asleep?

Goodness. It’s not like I can read it to myself out loud.

Eventually, Lloyd gave up. Even though he had somewhat gotten used to his senses and could go on with his daily life and supervise the construction, getting sleep at night was a hopeless endeavor. There was no way to cure his insomnia, and he couldn’t neglect his construction site for much longer.

Fine. It’s not like this is my first time being sleep-deprived.

Abruptly, he recalled his days back in South Korea, particularly the days before he filed for college leave of absence. It was the most physically and mentally draining time in his life. Even when he hadn’t healed from losing his parents, Lloyd had to survive alone and work part-time. He also had school and heaps of assignments. There was just not enough time for everything, so he wished he had two bodies because he couldn’t overlook either side.

As such, Lloyd decided to do his best and ace everything. But there was one problem. Sleep. He couldn’t sleep at night. Whenever he closed his eyes, he began to see things, probably because of the pain of losing his parents or the haunting images of their last moments. His heart even felt stifled. Unable to sleep properly, he tossed and turned through the night. That period marked the harshest time period in his life, wherein he had to brace himself and remain strong even when his sleep deprivation, fatigue, trauma, and stress caused him to get regular nosebleeds.

At least I’m doing better than back then. My heart is in peace. I’m well-fed with nutritional food. I have people who wash clothes and clean on my behalf.

His current life differed from the period when he lived on plain rice and kimchi. He had servants to wash his clothes and clean his room and people who supported him by his side. This place was heaven. Thinking so, Lloyd accepted his insomnia and went out to the site. Every day, he was covered in sunlight and dust. The dam construction was not an easy project.

I've got to keep it as simple as possible. Stay faithful to the dam's main purpose. Exclude any complicated features. It just needs to be strong and sturdy.

The first task ahead of them was changing the direction of the river and drying the empty space left behind for construction.

It goes without saying that I can't build the dam when the water is still flowing. In order for the construction to continue, I have to redirect the current of the river even if it means I'll have to reverse it again later on.

So, Lloyd dug for a spillway to allow the direction of the river flow to change directions. He then built a temporary cofferdam upstream and downstream of the main dam. The upstream cofferdam directed the river to the spillway and blocked the water from flowing to the main dam.

As for the downstream cofferdam, its role was to prevent the diverted river water from overflowing and sinking the main dam construction site. As such, the spillway was dug as deep and wide as possible. The cofferdam for the upstream was built using the fill dam format, wherein soils and rocks were piled up in the rip-rap format. The measurement followed the design Lloyd had finished in advance. When he completed everything, the site for the main dam dried and smoothened. It was now time to begin the actual construction.

"You all can't be thinking that it's time for a break, right? Everyone let's get to work! Work!" Lloyd encouraged the workers all the more while keeping their shift schedule in mind and strictly complying with the established safety measures. He didn't give any time for slack. The reason was simple.

That's the only way for us to quickly finish the construction! It'll also help with my insomnia! I barely get any sleep at night and can't bear to watch

you all cheerfully take a break! So, you should all be pushing yourselves to finish your work!

Lloyd planned to hurry his workers and finish the project swiftly. That way, he could activate the Jewel of Truth and find out if the solution for the incoming disaster required any spending of the RP.

If the solution doesn't require RP, I'll do anything I can to get more of it and level up my manaheart.

If so, he would be completely free from insomnia. That became his ray of hope and source of motivation to passionately put pressure on the workers. His plan worked as the construction progressed without a hitch. The core part of the main dam, which would support the heavy weight of the structure, was completed.

Next, Lloyd removed topsoil and alluvial soil from the area until the bedrock appeared. He then mana-blasted it to create a slope with infinite holes, which were then filled with cement. After, he grouted the areas where water would pool when the dam was ready.

This will essentially be a giant basin made of cement.

This was the only way to make the dam sturdy. It was more complicated than erecting a wall and trapping water behind it. Once the foundation was fully constructed, he proceeded to the most important portion of the project, the main dam. Lloyd referred to the Tibi Dam of Spain for the design.

Just like how the Tibi dam was built, Lloyd stacked together thick layers of limestone to build the structure. The interior of the dam was built using natural stone and cement. The exterior was made using uniformly sized rocks that minimized any gaps from appearing. In the end, they both came together to form a stable and dense arch. Lloyd simultaneously worked on constructing the Jewel of Truth at the same time.

Of course I have to. I need to finish it while the dam is still empty.

That was how he could make sure his construction of the Jewel of Truth would go smoothly. Thankfully, it was a relatively easier project than the dam.

It's a relief that I have a detailed blueprint.

Lloyd dutifully followed the Jewel of Truth blueprint, raising the foundation on the spot he had marked before. There, he inserted the sculpture he had found in the Mermaid Kingdom. After putting together a pyramid that resembled the Tomb of the General, he laid, inserted, and placed together all the key materials for the jewel.

Great. Let's continue on just like now. Just like now!

The construction processes in place couldn't go any smoother. There hadn't been any accidents, even minor ones, or other big challenges. Everything was progressing so nicely that Lloyd happily wished all his construction projects would be this relaxed.

One month later. Two months later. Three months later... One day, after six months passed, in the very morning Lloyd was finishing the final stage of construction for the dam and the Jewel of Truth...

Fwoosh!

Suddenly, a brilliant ray of light enveloped the construction site, and an entity no one ever anticipated to see emerged. He had a ring of iridescent light on his head and two fiery loops wrapping his whole body. This entity held the iron mace of punishment on one hand and the order of the demolition of illegal architecture on the other. It was Raphael the Throne, the Director of Inspection.

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Chapter 316: An Angel Has Descended (1)

Raphael the Throne was a renowned angel with an unrivaled reputation. Was it because he possessed special powers? Or because of his irreproachable personality? No. In the distant past, Raphael used to be like the rest of the angels. He belonged to the Angels choir, the lowest of the ranks, spending all his days studying at the Angel Academy. Raphael had aspired to pass the heavenly public official examination until he luckily succeeded and became a public official of the heavens.

That was how ordinary he was, and those around him expected nothing more from him. Since Raphael had merely just passed the examination for the Angels choir, everyone believed that his career would follow the standard path: To be harassed with complaints coming up from the lower realm until he was promoted to an Archangel. Only this time, he'd be harassed by Principalities angels. And if he was unlucky, he would end his career as one of the Principalities angels. If he did okay, he'd join the Powers. That was the typical career track for angels. But if he got lucky, he would be one of the Virtues angels until he honorably retired. This was a realistic and ordinary future to dream of, and everyone expected nothing more from Raphael.

But Raphael proved them all wrong in contrast to his unremarkable performance as a student. When he was left to deal with complaints, Raphael showed a completely different side of him. He became steadfast in his job and never procrastinated on any task that was given to him. Every complaint that came in the form of prayer each day was fielded and resolved like clockwork, and the administrative measures, once decided, were executed on the spot without exception or concession. No form of compliment or flattery could curry favor with him, and his principled work ethic eventually prompted him to boast an unrivaled productivity among his peers.

As a result, Raphael's career advanced at a historic speed. In less than 100 years since he was appointed as part of the Angels, he was promoted to be

an Archangel. Within 50 years, he rose to join the choir of Principalities. This shocked everyone.

But that was just the beginning. He continued to excel in his job and showed exemplary skills in managing corruption in all the offices he supervised. The offices managed by him served as a leading example for others to follow in heaven. Eventually, the stigma that heavenly officials were lazy sleazebags disappeared.

Thanks to this, Raphael earned countless commendation medals and awards and became a superstar among the panel for promotion. After he advanced above the choir of Powers and Virtues, high-flying Raphael easily joined the Dominion before becoming one of the Thrones angels in just a few thousand years.

His career flourished once more when he earned the position of the "Director of Inspection of the Under Realms," equivalent to being the right-hand man of Gabriel the Seraphim, the highest-ranking angel in heaven. Raphael had started out as part of the Angels but climbed up to the rank of the Throne. His rapid advancement hadn't stopped, however. Chances were that he could become a Cherubim or Seraphim. Appropriately, Raphael's presence exuded a distinct air of magnificence in heaven, and that hadn't changed as he stood in front of the Frontera Fiefdom.

"Hmm." Raphael's emerald eyes raked over the creatures past his iridescent light. Countless humans. Skeleton soldiers. The Bone Dragon. Lines formed in between his brows.

Skeletons. Bone Dragon. I can't believe there are so many creatures that defy nature, and what is worse is the humans. They are not terrified by these creatures. What happened here...?

The place was a mess, and Raphael wondered why.

A strong mana has been used to freeze the flow of time. This is giving me a headache. That human in particular.

Raphael’s gaze stopped at one spot, and he saw the man shudder at his gaze. “I am making this inquiry as part of my duties as a public official of heaven. Are you Lloyd Frontera?”

Frontera? Frontera... Frontera...?

His voice emitted a divine ripple that spread across the surrounding area, causing the skeleton soldiers and the Bone Dragon to tremble. The same went for Lloyd.

Ack!! My ears!

Lloyd’s body firmly trembled against his will. The booming echo of the divine voice from this strange figure in front of him was too much for Lloyd’s ears, which were overly sensitive due to his swordmaster syndrome. It felt like his ears were about to burst.

“Argh... Yes. And?” Frowning, Lloyd finally managed to answer. Deep down, he wanted to bicker and protest the thoughtless intrusion, which could have potentially caused an accident or injury. But he suppressed the desire when his vigilant mind noticed the holy light glowing around the figure and the imposing aura he gave off in his voice.

I don’t know what he is, but he’s surely someone important. I shouldn’t thoughtlessly antagonize him now. First, I’ll figure out who he is and what he wants.

Quickly reading the room, Lloyd asked, “Excuse me, but who are you?” He frowned, the pain in his ears still there.

“I am Raphael the Throne, the Director of Inspection.” Raphael frowned, too. “Lloyd Frontera and the silver-haired human beside you. I take it that you two have recently visited Hell. You both reek of its stench.”

“Th-that’s—”

“It is all right. That is not the reason I came down.” Raphael flatly interrupted before Lloyd could explain himself and held up a holy scroll in

his hand. After opening it in a dignified manner, he recited its content in a steadfast and solemn voice. “An order to demolish an illegal structure of the mundane world. Developer. Human Lloyd Frontera. Demolition building. The Jewel of Truth. Aotearoa.”

“Excuse me?” Lloyd shot a look of surprise.

“The following structure,” Raphael nonchalantly went on, “Has been banned from construction due to its ability to reveal secrets that must not be revealed. Therefore, as per Paragraph 1 of Article 8 in the Special Enforcement Act of the Maintenance of Illegal Architecture and Paragraph 1 of Article 5 of the Executive Order under the same act, I hereby decree the demolition of this qualifying structure.”

Dazed by the news, Lloyd said, “Wait, please wait...”

Raphael ignored Lloyd. “Notice. In the event you object to the demolition order, you can file a complaint for the cancellation of the order through a desperate prayer within 30 days of the demolition order being issued. However, per Paragraph 3 of Article 8 of the abovementioned law, the demolition must take place if your plea is dismissed.”

“What is happening?” Lloyd let out an exasperated sigh.

“In other words, the Jewel of Truth you are currently constructing is a class one illegal structure in the upper realms. As such, you must cease its construction at once and demolish it.”

Lloyd cocked his head in sheer confusion, trying to make sense of this senseless interruption.

At last, Raphael folded the scroll and looked at Lloyd. “Are there any objections?”

“Yes!” Lloyd bellowed at once. How could he not? He didn’t know what else to say.

What? The Jewel of Truth is illegal? What in tarnation does he mean? Why should I stop my construction and demolish the jewel?

This didn't make any sense to Lloyd. He had worked hard to collect the key construction materials for the Jewel of Truth. He was nearly about to finish its construction.

This angel turns up from the sky and says what? That I must demolish the jewel because it's illegal? What does he expect me to do? Kneel down on the ground and obey his order because the decision came from the higher-ups in the heavenly realms or wherever it was. Like heck, I would. Ha! This is outrageous.

A sudden desire to slap that bastard of an angel with his shovel came over him for blurting out such nonsense. Lloyd wanted to demand why he needed permission from them when the construction was happening in his own world. He wanted to kick the glowing creature out of his fiefdom for trespassing on his territory.

But Lloyd decided not to do that. Instead, he let go of the shovel. Instead of raising his voice, he cleared his throat. Instead of kicking the angel out, he relaxed his eyes and put on a friendly expression on his face. And he feigned an ever so gentle smile.

"Excuse me? Mister Throne Angel?" Lloyd's voice sounded desperate.

"It's Raphael," remarked Raphael calmly.

"My, okay. Mister Raphael?" asked Lloyd pleasantly.

Raphael didn't say anything.

Taking this as a sign to continue, Lloyd added, "It must have been very difficult to come all the way down here with your busy schedule. Have you had a chance to eat?"

"I did."

“Haha, you did? How about then having a cup of tea as a snack? It must be your first visit here in a while.” Lloyd smiled.

However, Raphael was adamant. “I already had a cup.”

“Oh, I see...” Lloyd was starting to run out of ideas. “Then how about we move over there to the break room and have a calm discussion about this matter in more depth? I just happen to put down a comfy sofa.”

“I would rather talk here.”

“Ehem...”

Lloyd feigned his harsh cough as if he was spitting up blood. He was extremely rattled. It wasn’t the angel’s abrupt emergence or the demolition order that rattled him the most. It was something else.

This one’s a straight arrow.

Lloyd perceived that this angel was unyielding and steadfast. But he didn’t give up. Still putting on a friendly smile, he tried to cut a deal with the angel.

“Ehem,” said Lloyd. “Then may I ask you something?”

“If you have an inquiry to make, go ahead.”

“Yes. If I build the Jewel of Truth here, is it going to harm the upper realms you belong to?” asked Lloyd.

“It will not. But your realm will be greatly impacted by it.”

“Pardon?”

“The Jewel of Truth,” explained Raphael, “is a structure that gives you insight into the secrets of the future. These secrets have the potential to bring chaos and tragedy to countless groups of creatures here.”

Nodding, Lloyd replied, “Aha. Is that why the structure has been banned?”

“Indeed.” Raphael nodded seriously. As for Lloyd, he thought...

What a load of crap. He’s stopping me because it can potentially cause danger? Then you might as well get rid of the knives, too! It’s a tool that can lead to murders, after all!

Lloyd felt wronged. Who do they think they are to determine such dangers and order him around? Suppressing the righteous anger surging in him, Lloyd smiled calmly. “Um, then, can I not use it carefully? Moreover, the said structure was something that already existed in the mythical ages.”

“Until it was destroyed after being determined as an illegal structure.”

“That is because of the great war that broke out—”

“The great war itself,” Raphael adamantly refuted, “Took place because of the intervention of the heavenly realms. The event was given as an opportunity for the creatures of this realm to demolish the Jewel of Truth with their own hands.”

Not getting what Raphael meant, Lloyd asked, “What do you mean by that?”

“We are done talking, so I will execute the demolition order at once.”

“Excuse me?”

Instead of explaining further, Raphael immediately jumped into action, catching Lloyd by surprise. The angel passed him, flew in the direction of the Jewel of Truth, and held up the giant mace. His intent was clear.

Crap! Really? He’s going to demolish the jewel just like that?

This angel was absolutely incorrigible. His ruthless actions reflected his belief that all mundane creatures had to acquiesce to any orders from heaven. This was the part that flipped Lloyd’s lid.

What a load of crap!

Lloyd wondered if this was what it was like for people who got kicked out of their homes by malicious land developers. He felt a sharp surge of anger, and before he knew it, he was dashing forward with a shovel in his hand. He passed the workers who were in shock from the angel's appearance, jumped over the construction equipment and materials, and stood in front of the angel.

But Lloyd didn't express his anger. Instead, he opted for a course of action far wiser than that. He suddenly got down on his knees. With a pious gaze toward the angel and in a genuine and altruistic voice, Lloyd thus recited his desperate plea.

"I pray to the Father, the Son, no, to the sky, cloud, wind, and all the pure souls of this land, including the angel in front of me!"

"What...?" Raphael flinched. Prayer? Now? Like this? Unperturbed by Raphael's gawping, Lloyd continued to speak aloud his pious prayers.

"Yes, I am. I lift my desperate prayer to you, dear angel. I will pray now, tomorrow, and the day after that. On and on. I will pray here until you grant my prayer until my hands and knees wear away into nothing. Will my prayer then reach your ears someday? If you say yes, which I beg you to, I will shed tears of repentance in sheer gratitude and praise your mercy."

"H-hold on..."

"That is why I continue praying! I will not stop until my desperate prayer reaches your heart! Right here! Endlessly! I shall pray!"

"Excuse me? Wait, stop for a moment." Flustered, Raphael stopped Lloyd. With a serious look on his face, Raphael asked, "Tell me, are you lodging an official complaint through this prayer?"

"Yes," Lloyd nodded right away. "Didn't you say it just now? That I can appeal for the cancellation of the demolition order through a prayer?"

Raphael didn't say anything.

Reading Raphael’s expression on his face, Lloyd replied, “It appears that my prayer has reached the heavens. I am very relieved.”

Still, Raphael didn’t reply.

Lloyd smiled in satisfaction. Raphael’s eyes, on the other hand, held a glint of dismay. And he wondered if this human might be a demon.

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Chapter 317: An Angel Has Descended (2)

I’ve heard stories of high-ranking angels but never saw one up until today...

Whoosh. Young Red Dragon Solitas was deep in thought as the wind blowing from the northern dam construction site brushed his skin.

This is troublesome.

Abruptly, he recalled what happened in the past few hours. He was going about his day like any other day, working hard in the studio of his master, Corgidus. This time, Solitas was preoccupied with shaping a rare piece of deer horn into a star. That was until he felt something.

A holy and oppressive storm of mana. A clear and relentless light that purified everything it touched. It was the first time I ever felt something like that on my skin.

Something was definitely off. His mind soon lost focus and ruined the deer horn decoration right before it was finished. But instead of glooming over the loss, Solitas leaped to his feet, bolted out of the studio, and ignored the shouts from his master, Corgidus. He decided it wasn’t the time to mind such trivialities. He immediately flew toward the spot that allowed him to see the dam construction site. Then, he started to think.

I wasn’t sure when I first felt the energy of a holy mana... I never imagined that a high-ranking angel would have descended down here.

High-ranking angels. Even though Solita was young, he had heard about them. And he knew one thing for sure.

He’d be stronger than me.

His mother’s teaching came to his mind.

She taught me that angels were strong. She told me how difficult it is to go against them because it’s not easy to leave damage on their body. It’s better

to fight three or four low-ranking angels or one mid-ranking angel if you're an ordinary dragon.

And today, the angel that came down to this fiefdom appeared to be much stronger than a low or mid-rank angel. Solitas knew this because of the two fiery, rotating rings burning behind the angel's back.

I remember what it is. Mother said it's the mark of a high-ranking angel.

As such, that angel over there was a high-ranking one. In other words, he was an unassailable opponent. Yet, the angel seemed to be in a fury. That was the problem.

I can clearly feel there's a hostile yet holy aura around him. Is he here because he has business with Lloyd Frontera? Is it because Lloyd Frontera froze the passage of time in this world outside his fiefdom? That could be it. What's going to happen now? He's not going to destroy this entire place, is he?

Thousands of ominous possibilities crossed his mind. What if the angel punished the fiefdom and turned this place into a pile of ash?

That can't happen!

Solitas found himself shaking his head.

Corgidus hasn't taught me everything about the art of jewel refinement. And if this fiefdom turns into a pile of ash, there will be no more sludge, which means I'll be out of work and can't learn the craft in return!

The ominous thought continued to play in his mind.

Then, I'll never be able to improve my terrible skills and master how to refine jewels. Without being able to keep a hoard of jewels in my cave, I won't be able to propose to anyone since I won't have any jewels to feed my children.

Just like that, he'd die alone as a bachelor.

I can never let that happen…!

Solitas felt a surge of desperation. He made a decision.

I'll observe the situation. And if Lloyd gets attacked, I'll step in and fight. I have to protect this fiefdom.

Solitas decided to bravely fight to fulfill his lifetime wish of getting married, even if the opponent was a high-ranking angel. He figured the fight would be doable with Javier and the Bone Dragon. Around the time his resolution was solidifying in his heart, Solitas heard a carefree and relaxed voice beside him.

"Hey, you there. You don't want to recklessly engage with an angel."

"Eh?"

Solitas was surprised by the sudden voice that came out of nowhere. Thinking how it was possible for anyone to sneak up on him, Solitas swiveled around at lightning speed.

"Who are you?!"

"Oh. The Dragon King."

Solitas saw a slouched man sitting on the grass. His eyes were half-open in sleepiness, and his voice sounded as if the mere act of speaking was too bothersome for him. There was something about him that gave off a lazy-ass vibe, and he seemed to epitomize the word "slacker."

But Solitas didn't lower his guard just yet. He wasn't going to be fooled by the man's relaxed appearance and aura around him. Since the man managed to sneak up on him, avoiding Solitas's senses, the latter could only wonder what abilities the former held.

In a graver voice, Solitas asked, "I asked who you are."

Whoosh... Solitas emitted an oppressive energy unique to dragons as he asked. But the indolent man gave a yawn.

“Ha...” Dragon King Verkis yawned. “I told you. The Dragon King.”

“The Dragon King?”

“Yeah.”

“You are the great and divine King Verkis?” huffed Solitas. “You?”

“Well, if you don’t believe it, then don’t. Anyway, you don’t want to get involved with an angel. It’s only going to complicate your life as a dragon.”

“What?” Solitas stopped.

Verkis grinned mysteriously. “The devils in Hell pretend to obey you if you overpower them, but the angels are different. They’re a terrible bunch of inflexible folks who play it exactly by the books and never back off on a decision unless they agree with it. They’re as flexible as a piece of iron.”

“I do not get what you mean...”

“And now,” Verkis kindly went on, “An angel, a high-ranking angel at that, made a direct appearance in our world. What does that tell you? It shows that he’s here to implement a decision that was already made. So, stay out of this, kid. You can’t bend an angel’s dogged will with your powers, and even if you do, you’ll only leave a bad impression and make your life miserable.”

Solitas, however, was defiant. “I do not care. Also, what did you just call me? A kid? How dare you call me that, and who are you?”

“I told you. Twice already,” Verkis sighed as if this conversation was starting to wear him out.

“The Dragon King? You are the great and divine King Verkis?”

“Yeah.”

Solitas couldn’t hold his rage anymore. “How dare you?! Do you think you will be safe even after impersonating him?”

Exhausted boredom came over Verkis's face at last. "Ha... How annoying. Should I just kill you now?" He was too bothered to explain or convince the young dragon, and instead, softly flicked his finger.

Flick! A ripple of mana appeared on his fingertip and wrapped Solitas's whole body.

"Eek?" As soon as the young dragon opened his eyes wide in surprise, a change came immediately.

Pop! A growing plume of smoke enveloped his body, and by the time the smoke thinned out, Solitas was gone. There was only a tiny red gecko.

"This is your punishment. Stay like that for a day," ordered Verkis. "You're going to believe my words now, right?"

The red gecko, Solitas, nodded.

"Okay. Good boy. But know it's too late even if you nod now."

Solitas simply stared at Verkis.

Verkis appreciated the silence. "Look how nice it is now that you're calm. You remind me of my salamander. You're exactly like it. My little Deoddeok that my wife took on her trip."

"Anyway," Verkis went on, "I have to fulfill the terms of my sponsorship to revive my beneficiary from death. That's why I'm out here, even though it's bothersome for me. So, stay quiet. All right?"

Solitas fiercely nodded his head in shock. He finally understood the meaning of Verkis's words.

Hold on right there...

Frightful chills ran over Solitas's body. At the same time, he also felt reverence. Swallowing dryly, he turned toward the construction site for the dam.

Beneficiary? Sponsored by the Dragon King? Lloyd Frontera is his beneficiary? And he's going to die today?

***

Should I just... kill him?

Such a thought crossed Raphael's mind. How could it not while he was currently facing Lloyd?

This human is making false prayers. And his attitude is nothing short of a demon's.

No, he could be worse than a demon, Raphael thought. The prayer this man was offering could not be any more impure. Behind it, there was only greed to purely gain something for himself. Furthermore, he had the audacity to be brazen as well.

"Now, my complaint has been filed officially, correct?" asked Lloyd earnestly.

Raphael felt repulsion and hatred for the gaze and smile Lloyd Frontera threw at him on his knees. Raphael's fists clenched on their own.

How dare he pray in this kind of manner.

Raphael was not pleased. Prayers weren't created for this purpose.

It is the final resort a desperate man from the lower realms can rely on to ask for help from the upper realms. When no one is out there to help the creature in their world, when there's no one they can lean on for support, when they are left completely alone, a prayer offers them a chance to seek help from the heavens.

With only such desperation in their hearts, would the heavens accept their words and forward them to the angels in the form of a complaint, which the angels would review and process.

Most prayers are accepted. That's how pure and desperate prayers usually are. Even if their prayers are not answered in the current life, they eventually actualize in their afterlife. That's how precious and significant sincere prayers are. But this man... How dare he offer this kind of prayer?

Raphael shuddered. He didn't want to accept the man's prayer. But he didn't have any choice but to accept it.

"Fine..." finally muttered Raphael. "Your sincerity has been accepted."

There was only one criterion for whether a prayer would be accepted as a complaint: Sincerity. Lloyd's brazen prayer, to Raphael's repulsion, met the criteria.

Even if it's not pure and with blemish, even if it's borne out of personal greed... it is still sincere.

Personal greed was sincere, and that was what Raphael found to be more disgusting and repulsive. Naturally, contempt filled his gaze as it fixed on Lloyd.

"Are you requesting for the cancellation of the Jewel of Truth demolition?" asked Raphael.

"Yes, that is it." Lloyd nodded fervently and clenched his fists.

It's working. I succeeded.

Lloyd hadn't been entirely sure about this tactic. He had simply taken his chance by remembering what the angel had read aloud. But to his relief, it worked, and Lloyd decided it was time to push forward.

Looking up at the angel, Lloyd said, "I would like to file an official complaint. Please cancel the order to demolish the Jewel of Truth."

"Do you have a basis for the cancellation request?"

"Of course I do." Lloyd collected his breath before speaking. "I am honestly curious. I do not understand what harm building the Jewel of Truth

will do to this world. Certainly, it is a mysterious building that can answer any question it is asked and has the potential to be used for evil. The thing is, however, does that not also mean that it can be used for good?”

When Raphael saw Lloyd stop, he said, “Continue.”

“Thank you, your grace. That is why I am making this request. Please cancel the demolition of the Jewel of Truth. If you are worried about the abuse of the building, I would be happy to set a condition for its usage.”

“What condition?” asked Raphael the Throne.

“Wouldn’t it be all right if you come down and watch over the jewel whenever it is at work?”

“Are you saying that you will use the Jewel only in the presence and under the supervision of an angel?”

“Yes. That is exactly what I mean,” said Lloyd.

“I see... I will forward your complaint above. Please wait.”

Raphael took a step back and closed his eyes, contacting his direct supervisor through the angelic ring on his head. An answer came immediately. Raphael opened his eyes and looked down at Lloyd. His eyes were now changed. They were glacial and adamant. The same change could be felt in his voice.

“Human Lloyd Frontera,” Raphael announced. “I received the answer to your request. In short, your request to cancel the demolition has been rejected.”

“Excuse me?” blurted Lloyd in shock.

“The Jewel of Truth holds the potential to divulge secrets that must not be revealed. As such, it is at the top of the list of structures that need to be demolished even in heaven, and that cannot be changed without a special cause.”

“Wait, hold on... By special cause, then-”

Raphael cut Lloyd short. “Your personal reasons do not constitute a special cause. Moreover...” His gaze toward Lloyd grew more glacier. “As I have notified you, in accordance with Paragraph 8 of Article 3 of the law, the demolition will take place instantly as your prayer request has been rejected.”

“Nothing more.”

With that, Raphael made a move. He immediately passed Lloyd and neared the Jewel of Truth before the latter could stop the angel. Standing on its top, Raphael raised his iron mace and prepared to strike down the Jewel top. Just then...

“Hold on!”

It was Lloyd who shouted. Before Raphael knew it, Lloyd was standing right in front of him and stopping the demolition. His breathing was raspy. This time, Lloyd neither kneeled nor looked up. Instead, he had his shovel aimed at the angel’s forehead as if to say, “Over my dead body!” Lloyd stared at Raphael with wide eyes, resisting and fighting hard.

What else can I do? What else can I do when this whole thing makes no sense?!

Lloyd felt wronged. He couldn’t lose the Jewel like this. He had to stop destiny and protect Count and Countess Frontera, Julian, and everyone else. He wanted to happily spend the rest of his life with them, who had become his family now. As such, the Jewel of Truth had to be erected. Lloyd resisted the angel with such resolutions in his head, ready to desist the intruder, come hell or high water. Over my dead body, Lloyd told himself as he tensed his eyes and bit his lips.

“Human Lloyd Frontera,” Raphael spoke. “Are you interrupting the completion of my heavenly duties?”

“Come again?”

“This is my last warning. Move away.” Raphael’s icy voice pierced into Lloyd’s ears. However, Lloyd remained and glared at the angel without giving any response.

Lloyd was hell-bent on staying rooted to the ground. He then racked his brain on what he had to do to stop that square, unyielding angel.

Think. Use your brain. Think of something smart. Think of something! Please!

Lloyd frantically racked his brain. But even before he could come up with something, Raphael made a chilling declaration on Lloyd.

“I have received your intent. Be aware that what is about to happen is on you. You have disobeyed a decision from heaven and attempted to stop an angel without permission. This is considered an attempt to interfere with the official duties of a heavenly official, and the punishment for it is immediate execution,” Raphael announced in a voice void of any emotion.

“What?!” Lloyd then saw what was nearing him.

Fwoosh! Lloyd saw the angel’s iron mace coming down from the sky, ready to slice through Lloyd and the Jewel of Truth. It charged down unopposed at lightning speed. Lloyd could feel the attacker’s determination.

“...!”

Lloyd’s eyes flew open. The trajectory of the mace came vividly in his eyes, thanks to his swordmaster syndrome. Its movement was read so clearly that Lloyd observed and caught the angel’s grip, movement, and weight shift. However, despite his hyper-sensitivity, he couldn’t react and dodge the attack.

My body can’t keep up with my senses.

Even though Lloyd’s senses bordered on the level of a swordmaster, his body was still equal to that of a high-level sword expert. As such, it failed to

react even when his eyes could see the incoming mace. Lloyd failed to move and avoid the attack. It was as if he had become a snail.

I can't avoid this.

Although he didn't want to, Lloyd imagined what would happen to him if the mace knocked him right in the head. Even then, the mace continued to move down, slicing through the air, crashing across the area, and charging down to strike his head.

Dammit.

Lloyd was dumbstruck. *Will my skull break just like this? Is this what I worked so hard for?* An empty scoff escaped him. Just then, a flash of light appeared before his eyes.

Clang!

Was I hit? The thought crossed Lloyd's mind. But it turned out not to be the case. Someone was standing in front of Lloyd, and the man had blocked the angel's mace. And soon, Lloyd heard an adamant and cold voice coming from the man.

"I, Javier Asrahan, the knight of the Frontera County, will immediately execute the trespasser for threatening my lord's family."

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Chapter 318: How to Corrupt an Angel (1)

“I, Javier Asrahan, a knight of the Frontera County, will immediately execute the trespasser for threatening my lord’s family.”

“Hmm...?” Raphael stopped at the icy, adamant voice and gaze directed at him. He couldn’t believe what just happened.

My mace was blocked? By a mere human?

Raphael was flustered and dumbstruck as his mace wasn’t any ordinary typical. It was imbued with the holy powers of heaven, so an inferior creature from the lower realms should never be able to block it, even if his attack was against a swordmaster.

How dare he!

As if it wasn’t enough to block the mace, this man also made an arrogant declaration. Raphael glared at Javier with an intense look in his eyes.

“Human of the lower realms... Your name is... Javier Asrahan. I suppose you did not think about the consequences of your action,” warned Raphael solemnly.

Javier didn’t respond.

“Foolish. I feel sorry for you. Your power to block the offense of a Throne angel amazes me, but it fills me with remorse to see you waste your talent and skills on such precipitous actions. Therefore, Javier Asrahan. Please step back and think again. You are committing the grave crime of obstructing the duties of a heavenly official.”

Thwack! Clatter! Raphael put more strength into his iron mace. But Javier’s sword was equally strong. It didn’t sway or shake against his. And Javier’s gaze was just as adamant as his sword.

Javier didn’t speak because he didn’t have to. It didn’t matter whether he was an angel. All that mattered was that this angel had threatened the well-being of his fiefdom.

There is nothing left to do but get rid of this angel.

Twang! Javier jerked his sword upward, bouncing the mace off.

Swoosh! Javier then lowered his body at lightning speed before closing in and setting a distance that allowed him to leave a fatal hit. He then rocked his sword’s trajectory.

Fwoosh! His sword emitted a brilliant aura and produced dozens of remnant light strands aligned to its shaky trajectory. As each strand glinted and changed hundreds of times, tens of thousands of brilliant remnants of the aura appeared. Raphael’s eyes shook in dismay.

Eh?

Raphael tried to track the changes to spot the real aura but failed before he could step back and distance himself. One of the tens of thousands of light strands thrust into his stomach.

Raphael sensed that the blow was unavoidable. But he neither tried to defend himself nor dodge the incoming blow. Instead, he simply proceeded to raise his mace as a counterattack, aiming toward Javier’s head. Then something extraordinary took place.

Fwish! Right before the sword penetrated Raphael’s stomach, the two fiery rings on his back suddenly rotated and unleashed themselves, blocking Javier’s sword strike.

Javier’s eyes trembled at the angel’s unexpected defense mechanism. But Javier was far from being perturbed. It only triggered him to lay more attacks. *Clang! Clang! Clang!*

Awakening hundreds and thousands of manahearts, Javier transferred the turbulent wave of mana into his sword. He soon became one with the

sword. He slashed, struck, stabbed, swung, and lashed out. *Thwack!*

Raphael didn’t stay put either. His iron mace reverberated when his heavenly rings awoke and received their holy and pure energy. His mace struck, punched, assaulted, crushed, and suppressed.

Kaboom! Javier. Raphael the Throne. Their collision created shock waves that went on for several miles and produced thick storms of dust. The impact shook the whole area. Lloyd, who had been watching their entire ruckus unfold, was caught in between them.

Ack!

And it was killing him. It was because of his swordmaster syndrome that had anomalously heightened his bodily senses.

Boom! Crash! Kaboom! Slash! Clang!

Ahh! Eek! Ugh! Argh! Ackk!

Every time Javier and Raphael’s weapons clashed and created a storm of shock waves, Lloyd had to cover his ears and roll sideways in agony.

Two of you! Stop! Ack!!

Lloyd was in agony. His ears were hurting already due to his swordmaster syndrome, which amplified the sound of anyone’s voice outside his own. The thundering sound booming from beside him made him feel like someone was throwing an EDM party inside his head. No, it actually felt like he had been transmogrified into a beetle trapped into a gigantic speaker at a heavy metal concert. Despite this, however, Lloyd didn’t just sit back and writhe in pain. He couldn’t stay put.

Ackk! This is nuts. I never expected such a messed-up situation to happen.

Beaten to a pulp by the noise and shock waves and despite his whole body shuddering, Lloyd forced himself up. He then opened his eyes wide and stared at the cloud of dust blooming around him until he could make out Javier and Raphael.

Ha... How did this happen? A clash with an angel?

The sight drew a sigh out of Lloyd. He wanted to avoid a confrontation with the angel at any cost because he knew what the novel had said about angels.

The novel said that these angels from the heavenly realms were equivalent to public officials on Earth who have control and power over global affairs.

As such, nothing good would come out of fighting against such creatures. It would be a complete loss for him. It was similar to how nothing good came out of antagonizing and making an enemy out of your supervisor at work. In the end, the subordinates would be the ones who would suffer from it. As such, Lloyd wanted to avoid having a conflict with the angel if he could help it. That was why he had desperately given a prayer and tried to have a discussion.

But it didn't work. So I guess there's nothing else I can do.

Lloyd felt bitter. Remorseful, too. But this was water under the bridge. The best thing he could do now was to mend the situation. Even if this clash made them an enemy of the heavenly realms, Lloyd resolved to desist Raphael from executing the outrageous demolition order of the Jewel of Truth.

And if my ties with them get completely severed... Well, then, I'll ask the Dragon King or the King of Hell to help me out.

Lloyd resolved in his heart that he would stop the restoration of destiny, even if it meant involving the corps of demons from Hell. With that, he watched the breathless confrontation between Javier and Raphael while rooting for the former.

Please! You can do it, Javier!

Lloyd knew not to interfere in the middle of their fight. And he was right for thinking so. Javier was a grandmaster, and Raphael was almost as strong as Javier. Seeing no place in the fight where he could jump in and help out

Javier, Lloyd concluded that he'd be like a mosquito in between two aggressive dinosaurs if he intervened.

That's why you need to win! Let's go! Come on!

Lloyd rooted for Javier while enduring the painful booming sounds and shock waves.

Thwack! Boom!

Okay, you're doing wonders, Javier! Push him more! More!

Clang! Clang! Clang! Clang!

Right! That's it! Hey! Over there! Ahh!

Kaboom! Boom!

Eh? Hey! Don't let him get to you! Stab him!

Thwack! Crash! Boom!

Ohh! Oh...!

Lloyd joyously exclaimed each time Javier succeeded in pushing Raphael back. And he mournfully groaned each time Javier retreated. In the process, one thing became clear to Lloyd.

It's a losing game for Javier if this fight drags out.

Lloyd's observation was on point. As the fight dragged out, Raphael was beginning to gain the upper hand. Javier seemed to have it at first. But that was only for a short period of time. Raphael started to become more relaxed over time, while Javier started to opt for a more defensive posture. Lloyd instantly realized why this was happening.

It's because of those fiery rings.

Lloyd paid attention to the two rings of fire that enveloped Raphael's body. And at that moment, they started to move again. *Blaze!*

They rotated and intersected each other before precisely blocking Javier's sword as if they predicted the trajectory of its movement. Afterward, they exploded. *Kaboom!*

It turned out that those rings did more than block against incoming attacks. They generated fiery explosions and shock waves while fending off Javier's strikes. Naturally, this prompted Javier to spend one more second regaining his balance, costing him the chance to lay simultaneous attacks. As such, even if Javier was originally in an offensive position, he was later forced to take on a defensive posture when his offensive streak began to falter.

Those rings are moving like a piece of artificial intelligence.

Their defensive powers were top-notch as well. Not only did they manage to stop Javier's grandmaster-level attacks, but they also absorbed the impacts of his blow and sent it back to him.

That's what's giving that angel the energy to just focus on his attacks. On the other hand, Javier...

Javier was in a completely different position. He had to focus both on his offense and defense. To paint a clearer picture, Javier was comparable to a traditional racer driving a manual car, whereas Raphael was...

He's driving an advanced AI-operated self-driving car, leaving the wheel to the AI as he enjoys a cup of coffee and a bag of chips.

Their fighting method had differences in terms of efficiency, which meant the level of strain put on each of them differed. In short, things would go badly for Javier if the fight continued to drag on longer.

I can't sit back and watch.

Thump! Thump! Lloyd's heart raced fast at the ominous prospect. He realized he had to do something, like getting rid of those fiery rings.

Otherwise, Javier would lose.

I can't let that happen. No one will be able to stop Raphael once Javier is gone. Dragon King Verkis? There's no guarantee that the bum is going to help me, even if he's my sponsor. No one, including me, will be able to stop the Jewel's demolition.

A sense of alarm swelled over him. Lloyd's brain started to tick at full speed.

Think. Come up with something. How can I help Javier to give him the upper hand in this fight? To help him win, what should I do? How do I turn the tide in his favor?

The current situation. The future awaiting them. Javier's strengths and weaknesses. Raphael's tactics and characteristics. Lloyd considered every factor he could see and predicted to develop a solution. He did the math. He made speculations with the clues he had. And finally, an idea popped into his head.

Oh, right.

It came to him.

The Knight of Blood and Iron. There was a brief explanation of the angels in the novel. The high-ranking angels. The Seraphim. The Cherubim. The Thrones... Right! The fiery rings of the Thrones angels!

According to the novel, the Thrones angels carried fiery rings that fended off all the attacks of their enemies and boasted an impeccable defense capability.

The source of their power was... That's right. Having a good and pure heart inside them.

A pure heart. A pure goodness that didn't have a single blemish. It was said possessing a righteous and pure heart was what powered their rings. In other words...

I just have to corrupt their pure hearts. How?

The answer was already clear. As soon as Lloyd came up with his course of action, he calmed his nauseated stomach and jumped to his feet. He then worked his legs to stand at the peak of the Jewel of the Truth. Javier and Raphael's fight was taking place on the ground. Lloyd cleared his throat as he looked down at them.

The way to corrupt an angel's heart. There is only one way that comes to mind.

For a split second, he felt wistful.

I didn't want to have this kind of reputation in my own fiefdom.

But his hands were tied. Stay on the fence any time longer, and Javier might lose out. Lloyd's time to act was now. And this was the most efficient and quick course of action.

Let's do it.

Lloyd resolved to himself. Finally, he opened his mouth. And then, he sang.

"You were created to be loved! Throughout your life, you are loved!"

Lloyd's off-tune cacophony thundered across the air. From then on, there came a rage-inducing sound that would propel even the most merciful saints to jump out of their graves and slap Lloyd in the mouth. The sound started to terrorize Raphael's eardrums.

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Chapter 319: How to Corrupt an Angel (2)

Singing. It was a skill that allowed someone to create multifarious sounds and melodies with their respiratory system and vocal organs. It was not just a skill, however. It was an art capable of tugging the heartstrings of its listeners. Raphael the Thrones adored this auditory form of art. As a public official, singing was his one and only source of invigoration amid his strict and methodic work environment.

I thought I was happy and felt lucky.

The music of the upper realms was beautiful. The melodies of Heaven boasted impeccable harmony. Raphael, thus, regarded his greatest blessing as being born a divine creature under heaven.

Listening to music never failed to wash away his day's worth of fatigue. It overwhelmed him with happiness and peace. The same went for today. As he descended into the lower realm, Raphael was determined to enjoy listening to Heaven's Symphony No. 2, his favorite song, as soon as he finished demolishing the Jewel of Truth, to wash away all the exhaustion with its clear, vivid melody. It was his reward to himself. But the reality, to his misfortune, was nothing less than a disgusting cesspool.

"Wh-what in the heavens?"

Raphael was beginning to have the upper hand and oppress his human opponent, who continued to put up a good fight despite his fiery rings. Nonetheless, he was confident that the tables would turn eventually and his enemy would start to crack with a little more pressure. That was when his ears picked up a terrorizing cacophony.

"You were created to be loved! Throughout your life, you are loved!"

Ack...

An avalanche of horror gripped him. He almost dropped the iron mace from his grip as he was suddenly overcome with the desire to cover his ears. The

music coming into his ears was plain horror. Its tune, rhythm, and everything else about it was wrong. The singer's screeching voice, too, sounded like a drowning hen.

Where could this sound possibly be coming from? Can this be considered singing? Wait, was this a demonic cry from Hell? Or a curse from the Purgatory? As he strove to collect his chaotic thoughts, Raphael swiveled to the sound's source. He then found Lloyd singing at the top of the Jewel of Truth.

"From the beginning, God has shown his love for you! As we greet and bless each other, love blossoms! Because you are with us, we experience tremendous joy!"

Stop it! Please stop it! Raphael begged inwardly as the words were lost in his mouth. A desire to suddenly offer a prayer for this human surged, followed by a desire to tear out his eardrums.

"Ack...!"

Wham! Just then, Raphael heard the booming sound of his fiery rings blocking a blow, which had come like a bolt of lightning. Raphael shuddered when he realized how the awful singing had distracted him.

Argh!

The blow didn't hurt Raphael. But it compromised his counterattack.

I was doing a good job of suppressing him. Tsk.

Grandmaster Javier. Raphael had been trying to defeat his difficult opponent through suppression. But now, all his momentum had dissipated after his momentary lapse of focus. As a result, the tables had turned against him.

Wham! Boom! Crackle! Javier's sword glinted in a series of motions as soon as it was liberated from the oppressive salvo of attacks from the angel. He was now on the offense and charged to strike down Raphael. His violent

attacks seemed to be ready to destroy Raphael’s fiery rings, which acted as his shield.

Arggh!

Raphael began to busily move as it was only a matter of time until his defense capabilities, however strong they were, would be neutralized by the blitzkrieg coming from his opponent. He couldn’t sit back and solely depend on his rings. As such, he looked up, trying to remain calm.

“Human Lloyd Frontera,” Raphael called as he deflected Javier’s sword. “I understand your desire to sing, but could you please stop your singing for a second, as your voice is not quite compatible with my tastes?”

Raphael believed that his gracious and cordial attitude would prompt Lloyd to accept his request and he would understand the former’s dismay. But Raphael could not be more mistaken.

Lloyd’s response came in the form of singing. “O suffering one, stretch your hand out! With the Lord’s promise, take your stand!”

This hymn was something Lloyd used to sing aloud on Sundays at the military when he attended church because they gave out chocolate-coated bread with marshmallows. Lloyd gave everything he had to sing this song aloud. Of course, he didn’t have to purposefully try ruining the song. He simply just tried his best to sing well. But it was just that his best efforts only strained his neck, making his veins pop and voice crack, ultimately perverting his singing into a screeching shrill. Raphael, upon hearing Lloyd’s hymn, writhed in excruciating agony.

“S-stop... Stop!”

Raphael shook his head as he trembled. Why was his day going like this? If he just finished his mission today, he could return to listening to his melodious song.

This singing... This sound... It’ll be stuck in my head even after a thousand years!

Chills ran down his spine. The desire to purify his ears swept through him. He held up his iron mace in desperation and wielded it roughly at Javier, who was charging at him.

Boooom!

Javier was pushed back into a distance when he blocked the mace. Having earned a second to himself, Raphael looked up and pleaded to Lloyd in a shaky voice.

“Please! Human Lloyd Frontera! Do not defile the value of a beautiful song and music!”

Lloyd fervently replied, “Avalokitesvara! The Heart of Prajna Paramita Sutra! He illuminated the Five Skandhas and saw that they were all empty!”

Just then, several lines of vein appeared on Raphael’s forehead. Raphael the Throne, the angel of justice and austerity, almost lost his patience and cursed aloud. He clamped his mouth shut.

I can’t curse. It’ll ruin my purity.

The pure heart represented the will of the heavens and was the source of his power. This meant his purity would be defiled the moment he yelled out curse words due to an emotional outburst. That meant the loss of his main source of power. Remembering that, Raphael strove to keep his mouth shut and push the curse words out of his thoughts. And then, he came to a decision. Since Lloyd wasn’t listening, he would have to forcibly stop the human from singing.

“Arggh!”

Boooom! Raphael leaped high and zoomed toward the peak of the Jewel of Truth to get to Lloyd.

Lloyd, however, didn’t stop singing, even when the raging angel was charging at him. He simply continued to sing with ease. Why? It was because of his new supporter in the fight.

Whoosh! Boom! A humungous tailbone swept the whole area and struck the incoming angel. Even though it barely had any impact, the effect was immense. Raphael was sent dozens of yards away. The tailbone belonged to no other creature than Draggy.

Clack! Crack!

Draggy stood tall in front of the Jewel of Truth after giving Raphael a taste of what it felt like to be a home-run baseball. It opened its chest wide as if to say no one could pass here and Lloyd would be protected. The Skeleton Corps joined Draggy.

Claack! Crack! Clack!

200 skeletons cracked noisily, and their clacking bodies added a special beat to Lloyd's singing, which successfully distracted Raphael one more time. Now, Raphael was losing his mind.

I beg you... Stop!

Raphael's face crumpled. This was a serious test of his patience, even for an angel. However, the situation turned for the worse when Javier suddenly appeared and launched a series of attacks. *Clang! Clang! Claaang!*

Javier's sword welted down on Raphael, leaving him breathless. Thousands of aura strands pressed him, and even though the fiery rings blocked most of them, he wasn't entirely uninjured.

"Argh... Urgh!"

Crunch! Raphael's two feet were now stuck deep into the ground, much like a nail hammered into a woodblock. His body started to crumple from the relentless blows.

"Ugh! Argh...!"

Raphael tried to save himself by producing shock waves with his fiery rings. But Javier's violent onslaught of attacks dissolved and absorbed them into his sword before using the force to strike harder.

This is not... good. At this rate, the mission will be a failure.

Raphael's eyes went ablaze with a sense of alarm. But it wasn't because he felt like he was going to lose.

My career has never seen any failure... I can't put a stain on my spotless record!

Raphael gritted his teeth. He had the world at his feet up until this moment with his impeccable performance. That was what had allowed his rapid promotions. It was also his source of pride to keep his nose to the grindstone as a perfectionist and serve the heavens by guarding the order of the world. Raphael regarded it as his reason for existence. But now, his pride was about to crumble, and he couldn't let that happen.

All I need to do... is stop that human from singing!

Raphael believed he'd then be able to regain his focus and exert all of his energy in the fight. At that time, he'd take care of the annoying silver-haired knight, demolish the Jewel of Truth, and save his pride in possessing a spotless track record for his job.

"Argh!!"

Thwack! Employing every bit of strength in him, Raphael rose up and bawled at the top of his enraged lungs.

"This is my last request and sincere warning! Human Lloyd Frontera! Please now! Quit your awful singing! If you do that, I will let all your actions of today slide and forgive you! And clear the charges against you for interfering with a public official from conducting his duties!"

Raphael was serious about this and wanted to negotiate if he could. If only he could stop that human from singing, he would gladly turn a blind eye to Lloyd for obstructing justice. He was sincere about this.

And now, since he had been generous and openly announced his concession, Raphael anticipated with bated breath that Lloyd would

acknowledge his sincerity and quit singing. He hung on to whatever little humanity was left on this earth with a faint sense of hope.

Soon, Lloyd’s response came. It came in the form of a yodel that tramped every ounce of humanity out of Raphael’s heart.

“She taught me to yodel! Yodel-oh-ee-dee! Diddly-oh-ee-dee!”

Raphael was shocked.

“She taught me to yodel! Yodel-oh-ee-dee! Diddly-oh-ee-dee-ay-dee!”

The terrorizing, ear-splitting cacophony only continued, and when Raphael saw the brazen smirk on Lloyd’s disharmony-producing mouth, something snapped in him.

“You...I...I asked you, and yet...!”

Crack! Clang! Boom! Crash! Amid Javier's restless, raiding blows, Raphael left his fiery rings to deal with them as he barreled upward in anger.

“Had I not asked countless times?!”

Now, there was nothing that Raphael’s vision caught, except for Lloyd. His eyes were completely focused on the human’s despicable face. Raphael hurtled like a raging bull or a charging tank toward Lloyd, hell-bent on iron-macing his face to a pulp.

“Why are you smirking?”

Boooom! The distance with Lloyd narrowed. Raphael’s fiery rings burned behind his back as they endured Javier’s blows and allowed Raphael to raise his iron mace high.

Twenty yards. Ten yards. five yards.

When Lloyd came within the hitting range, Raphael bawled in anger, “Did you like that now, you bastard? Dammit!”

The moment the word “Dammit” spilled out of Raphael’s mouth...

Fwoosh... Puff.

Abruptly, Raphael’s two fiery rings were put out. The fire vanished. The rotation stopped.

“Huh?”

Raphael stopped dead in his tracks. Just then, Javier’s sword glinted from behind him. *Slash!*

Past the extinguished fiery rings, Javier’s aura storm engulfed Raphael’s body.

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Chapter 320: Every Little Bit Helps (1)

“Eh...?”

Slash! Raphael froze at the unexpected turn of events. A shaft of shock rushed through him at the unbelievable sight that caught his eyes.

The fire in the rings is... gone.

Raphael could not believe it. This was the first time that this had happened in thousands of years, and Raphael knew why.

It’s my fault. I allowed myself to curse.

He had failed to suppress his momentary emotional outburst that he had never before experienced during his time as an angel. As such, rage got the better of him despite his benevolence and mercy. The price he paid for defiling his purity was a heavy one.

Clang!

Ack! Raphael felt an intense pain in his back. It was Javier who had landed a forceful strike on him. Soon, Raphael was engulfed by thousands of aura strands from the swordmaster.

Fwish!

The world blinked in Raphael’s eyes. Every ounce of energy in him left his body as if he was electrocuted, and his knees reflexively buckled.

“Eh... Argh!”

Were my legs this feeble? Was the iron mace I carried around this heavy? At last, Raphael knew.

I lost.

He felt his body roll off the Jewel of Truth and was unable to stand back up. His shivering body and wobbly legs refused to listen to him, even though he wanted to stand up. He was glad that he was an angel as his sturdy body had saved him from being slashed by Javier's sword. However, this was still the most serious injury he had ever received throughout his life.

I suppose this is the capabilities of a grandmaster from Earth.

Raphael's initial impression of Javier had been mere amazement after seeing his fiery rings block the latter's attack. But now that his body received a direct hit from him, he felt an almost chilling sense of awe. But on the other hand, he was...

Pathetic.

He had lowered his guard because he was a high-ranking angel and his enemy was a mere human. His confidence and certainty had eventually turned into arrogance.

I thought too lightly of this job.

He had never failed a mission and always dealt with whatever he was given. That was why he thought it would be the case this time as well. The reality, however, was different.

Lloyd Frontera. Javier Asrahan. Who are these humans?

Feeling his strength and consciousness fade away, Raphael introspected and chewed over his insolent mistake. Meanwhile, Lloyd and Javier spoke.

"Hey, are you okay?" asked Lloyd after clearing his strained throat.

"Yes, I am fine. Except for my defiled ears," quipped Javier.

"Tsk... Even then, you were able to take a breather thanks to me."

"By the way," Javier said, ignoring Lloyd's question, "you were too reckless back there, Young Master."

“Reckless? How?”

“Just a while ago. The iron mace could have killed you if I was even a little late.” Javier looked at him solemnly.

“I trusted you.” Lloyd shrugged.

Javier narrowed his eyes.

“I mean it,” pressed Lloyd. “I knew if I pushed the angel into cursing and created a weakness for it...”

Javier asked, “That I would take care of everything afterward. Is that what you believed?”

“Yeah.”

Javier narrowed his eyes some more.

“What? You don’t believe me?”

“Well, of course—”

“Just believe me in times like this,” blurted Lloyd. “Come on. By the way, what should we do now?”

“I wonder too,” remarked Javier with equal uncertainty. “Should we chain him up for now?”

“I don’t think that’s enough. He’ll easily be able to snap through something like chains once he recovers his strength.”

“You have a point, Master Lloyd.” Javier nodded. “What do you want to do then?”

“Well. I should talk to him first.”

Lloyd walked toward the angel and asked a question.

“Excuse me, over there. Mister angel?”

Javier narrowed his eyes some more.

Raphael, in his fading consciousness, found Lloyd to be extremely shameless. But Lloyd continued to speak.

“Um, this is kind of funny for me to say this after all that we did, but... Raphael the Throne? Your Grace? If you think about it, you started all of this today. Don’t you agree?”

Raphael simply listened without giving any response.

Lloyd continued to speak. “You threw the first jab... And we had no choice but to defend ourselves and our property. So, let’s make this point clear. What we did was self-defense. Do you understand, Your Grace?”

Javier narrowed his eyes some more.

Raphael didn’t want to understand. He wasn’t interested in listening to this human’s drivel.

I only came here to complete my heavenly duties.

This job was entrusted to him by his supervisor, Gabriel the Seraphim, and the demolition had been decided after a long discussion between the directors and managers inside their department. As such, he only was doing what he was told to do.

But I failed. No, I am about to fail.

Raphael never experienced something like this before. He hated every aspect of his current situation, his helpless surrender, and Lloyd’s inconsiderate ignorance and chatter.

Does this mean my career advancement will stop here?

The chances were likely. After all, he had come from the lowkey rank of an Angel. The only thing that enabled his promotion was his impeccable

record. But now, it was about to be ruined.

Is that why I am...sad?

Raphael considered the question for a moment. No, he wasn't sad that there would be a blemish on his record. He was frightened and saddened over the possibility that he may fall into despair and never be able to do greater things for both Heaven and Earth than he did before. As such...

I mustn't let this stop me.

The heavens and the world had a lot of things to do before they got better, and Raphael was ready to put more effort into that end. As such, he couldn't fail. He needed more status and power until he became useful to the world.

That's my reason for existing!

Raphael clenched his teeth after coming to a decision. He could not give up his duty now. Something had to be done. Anything.

I don't care if I can't go back to Heaven for ten or so years!

He had lived for tens of thousands of years. Ten years would pass in a blink of an eye. As such, he decided to double down and jumped into action.

The moment the venomous resolution bloomed in Raphael's heart, the ring over his head glimmered and got sucked into his body. Soon, an immense amount of holy power started to surge and bubble inside his body until it exploded.

Kaboom!

By the time Lloyd widened his eyes and raised his arms at the unexpected burst of holy energy, both of his feet were already off the ground. No, more precisely, he was being catapulted into the air.

"Master... Lloyd!"

Lloyd picked up a faint, frantic shout belonging to Javier. He reflexively held out his toward his knight, thinking that the latter did the same. He was right. His finger brushed Javier’s but failed to grasp it.

Sent away into the air, Lloyd lost sight of Javier after they grazed past each other.

What’s going on...?

Every passing moment came in slow motion because of Lloyd’s heightened senses. He felt how he was getting further from Javier, sent off the ground, and hurled into the air amid the booming, explosive noise and shock waves until he landed on the peak of the Jewel of Truth.

Thwack!

Lloyd wondered if his whole body had been crushed. Was this what it felt like to be hit by a truck? He couldn’t breathe, and he couldn’t even move a single one of his fingers. His body lay flatly on the ground.

Ha... Ha...

Lloyd doggedly grasped his fading consciousness, assured that he wasn’t dead yet. Afterward, he hurriedly awakened his manaheart and sent mana throughout his body for a quick check-up. Thankfully, no bones were broken, and his organs were all fine. However, he couldn’t rise or move around due to the still significant damage he received from the impact of the fall.

Dammit. That angel is so needlessly strong.

It never occurred to Lloyd that such an explosion would be possible when Raphael had lost after Javier’s sword strike. He never imagined that Raphael had enough strength to cause an uproar and throw a stronger attack.

Did he... absorb his overhead ring?

It appeared so. Lloyd spotted Raphael emerge from the dusty storm, spread his wings of light, and charge straight toward the peak of the jewel. Raphael looked completely fine, uninjured from Javier's attack. There were only brilliant rays of light enveloping his body and the mace in his hand.

Dammit.

Lloyd could sense that Raphael was charging forward to simultaneously destroy him and the Jewel of Truth. Breathing hard, Lloyd struggled to rise up but couldn't. He turned his head and stared at Raphael. Just then, Javier suddenly came into his vision and blocked the angel's mace.

Crash! Another shock wave spread across the area. Javier's body trembled as his feet slid several yards back. Raphael, on the other hand, was completely unaffected. A furrow appeared between Javier's eyes.

Javier narrowed his eyes some more.

Javier felt his hands tingle in pain. His manaheart and mana circle were now running wild in alarm. That was after just blocking the mace one time.

He's different from earlier.

Javier's eyes tensed when he realized he was now going up against a different kind of enemy. The speed and strength weren't the same, and the blow a moment ago proved it. Even if Raphael had put a lot of strength into his blow just now and he hardly had any time to put up a good defense, Javier never thought one blow would put this much strain. Javier coldly assessed his opponent.

Now, he has the same amount of strength as a grandmaster, even without his fiery rings.

Javier had no way of knowing how that happened nor the time to dwell on it. Right now, his job was crystal clear.

I will not retreat.

Grab! Veins popped in Javier's knuckles, and his eyes held a glint of intense determination. He would root his feet to the ground and not take a single step back. He would protect Master Lloyd and the jewel, come hell or high water, particularly the former. But in the process of solidifying his resolution, a thought interrupted him.

But why?

A question suddenly pestered him. Why was he trying to protect Lloyd? While throwing his own safety out the window? All of a sudden, his decision seemed odd.

Because he is the son of my lord? No. That is not why.

That Lloyd over there wasn't real. He was a fake. So, technically speaking, he wasn't the lord's son. That he was protecting Lloyd because he was the lord's son made no sense.

And yet, why am I trying so hard to protect him?

He had no way of knowing. But one thing was clear. It was a very simple matter.

I want to protect him. Lloyd is my true master in my heart.

Lloyd was his friend. And now, Javier wanted to protect Lloyd. He would sincerely protect him with everything he had.

So, come at me.

Javier's eyes flashed with resolution, and he aimed his glinting sword toward Raphael. His body gave off the serious determination that he would never take a step back in protecting Lloyd. At the same time, a string of messages appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes.

Ding dong.

Eh...?

Lloyd was losing consciousness when the dinging noises woke him back up. His eyes opened, and he saw what was in front of him.

[Javier Asrahan has finally become aware of his feelings of friendship and loyalty toward you deep inside his heart.]

[His impression of you has greatly changed.]

[Deep inside him, you have become “Someone I genuinely wish to protect” from “Someone I am forced to protect.”]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by 45 points.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: +68]

[You have earned 810 RP by improving your relationship with a main character.]

[Current RP: 9,385]

[The intimacy level with Javier Asrahan has increased two levels from <Average Favor> to <Close Friendship>.]

[You have earned 200 RP as a bonus for the upgrade.]

[Current RP: 9,585]

Dang.

This message was not expected. It, however, wasn’t the end.

Ding Dong!

[The Commander of the White Cavalry, Valeradi Blanc, was moved by Javier Asrahan’s action.]

[He has always considered you his lord.]

[He has gripped the shovel and risen up for you.]

[Your likeability with Valeradi Blanc has increased by 1 point.]

[Current RP with Valeradi Blanc: +59]

[You have earned 9 RP by improving your relationship with a main character.]

[Current RP: 9,594]

What the?

Lloyd became goggle-eyed. Sir Blanc? Against Raphael, the angel? Fight him? It wasn't over, however. A cascade of messages continued to appear as if the system was grinning at his widened eyes.

Ding Dong! Ding Dong! Ding Dong!

[The vice commander of the White Cavalry, Orlando, has shouted.]

[He has willingly grabbed the shovel to join the combat and protect you.]

[Your likeability with Orlando has increased by 2 points.]

[Orc warrior Arosh is flailing his nose as he watches your predicament.]

[Arosh has dropped everything and is running over with his bulging muscles.]

[Your likeability with Arosh...]

[Elf archer Siroko's ears perked up.]

[Siroko still remembers the delicious taste of the barbecu you personally grilled in the past and determines that he cannot lose such a precious friend like you.]

[Siroko joins the combat to help Javier's solitary battle to protect you.]

[Your likeability with Siroko...]

[Engineering Corps soldier Rexton raises his pickax.]

[He shouts and urges others to protect you, their young master.]

[Engineering Corps soldier Arbok...]

[Orc warrior Tuarek...]

[White Calvary lancer Blaser...]

Ding dong. Ding Dong!

Messages appeared in series, one after another, with no sign of stopping. The 500 lancers of the White Cavalry, hundreds of orc warriors, elf archers, and human soldiers united their efforts to protect Lloyd, and his likeability with them continued to increase bit by bit. Even though the rewards of RP weren't much when considered separately, the actual sum became significant because there were about 2,000 individuals in total.

Ha...

Lloyd swallowed. *Shazam!*

Just like that, he was now earning heaps of RP that he could use to become a swordmaster.

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Chapter 321: Every Little Bit Helps (2)

Is that...?

Lloyd unconsciously gulped. Hundreds of messages continued to appear with no end in sight, making it impossible for him to give them a proper read. But skimming through them was enough to awaken his fading consciousness.

Unbelievable... My RP is rising like the stock market during the 2008 housing bubble.

Utterly dazed by the whole thing, Lloyd rubbed his eyes, his hands shaking. When he read the messages again, he once again confirmed that he wasn't dreaming.

Ding Dong! Ding Dong! Ding Dong!

[White Cavalry member Tivoli holds up his shovel to protect you.]

[Orc warrior Equinox roars and his heart is burning with spirit.]

[Elf archer Mehari hardens her resolve as she remembers the meat you grilled for her previously.]

[Engineer Camaro convinces his friends that he cannot lose you here.]

[Skeleton One Leg Short rushes forward, clacking its bones.]

Everyone burned with an eager resolution to protect Lloyd and held up their shovels and pickaxes to fight the angel. Seeing this, he grew apprehensive.

Will they be all right?

Their opponent was a mighty angel, whom even Javier couldn't easily defeat despite his status as a grandmaster. Lloyd wasn't sure the White Cavalry members, orc warriors, elf archers, Engineering Corps, and Skeleton Corps would be safe. Soon, his concern materialized.

Boom! A noise came from Javier and Raphael's collision. It was a collision between two transcendental powers, with Javier making history by showcasing his superhuman powers and Raphael unleashing his full capabilities after absorbing the angel ring. Their clash produced fierce, tsunami-like shock waves, knocking down and pushing away everything and everyone in their way.

"Ackkk!"

"Eek!"

"O-oink!"

Despite their bravery, agility, and strength, the White Calvary members, elf archers, and orc warriors, as well as the Engineering and Skeleton Corps, were all scattered away and rolled on the ground like styrofoam beads in front of a fan on its highest setting against the strong wind. But they didn't easily give up.

"The White Cavalry... Never backs down in front of an enemy!"

"Orc warriors, fight! Oink!"

"We will not retreat without a fight!"

"Engineers! Let's show him what our well-built muscles can do!"

Those rolling on the ground quickly got to their feet, their eyes burning with resolution. They once again picked up their shovels and pickaxes, and each time they did, a string of messages appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes.

Ding Dong! Ding Dong Dong! Ding Dong!

[White Cavalry member Berlingo has made a resolution to fight for you.]

[Your likeability with the Berlingo has increased by 1 point.]

[Current RP with Berlingo: +41]

[You have earned 3 RP by improving your relationship with a main character.]

[Current RP: 17,673]

[Orc warrior Tycan’s muscles are bulging with more intensity.]

[Your likeability with Tycan has increased by 2 points.]

[Current RP with the Tycan: +39]

[You have earned 2 RP by improving your relationship with a main character.]

[Current RP: 17,675]

[For you, Elf archer Cayenne will...]

[Engineer Cherokee swears to protect you...]

[Current RP: 17,891]

[Current RP: 18,741]

[Current RP: 20,1...]

[Current RP...]

“...”

It was outrageous. He couldn’t believe how much his RP increased. Lloyd found himself dryly swallowing again, and only now did it plainly dawn on him what had happened while he was half-conscious on the ground.

It looks like I’ve been able to form a good network at the very least...

Lloyd pieced together what had happened. He fell. Then Raphael tried to end him. But Javier fiercely defended him against Raphael. That was when everyone was provoked to raise their weapons and protect him by joining

the battle. It didn’t matter to them that they were going against an angel. This eagerness of theirs to fight for him must have been what sparked the increase in likeability.

Thanks to that, I’m raking in RP now.

The 500 members from the White Cavalry. The hundreds of orcs and elves working on the dam construction. And the Engineering Corps and Skeleton Corps. Even though the rewards of RP weren’t much individually, they added up to an extraordinary amount together.

Ha. It’s like collecting a dollar from each resident in a city with a population of one million.

The outcome was incredible. Feeling his heart pound, Lloyd looked at the last message.

[Current RP: 23,534]

And at last, Lloyd was able to garner a shockingly large amount of RP. It was so large that it had immediately jerked his fading consciousness back to life.

I need to do something with this. Anything.

Just then, his gaze traveled to Javier’s back and Raphael wielding the iron mace to break the former’s defense. He then watched another shock wave scatter everyone into the air.

Do I have enough to become a swordmaster?

He could be able to help if he became one. Even though he wouldn’t be able to fight at the same level as Javier, Lloyd presumed he would at least be able to help somewhat. He knew this was the time to be clever, and racked his mind for a plan.

I did manage to amass a lot of RP. But is investing most of it to become a swordmaster a good idea? What if it requires me to use all of my RP? Then

what? What happens afterward? What if I need the RP to stop the restoration of destiny?

Such concerns suddenly filled his mind. But soon, he shook his head.

No. This isn't the time to think about the future. Tomorrow has yet to arrive, and the current moment is what's in front of me.

Right now, it was time to stop Raphael. Otherwise, the Jewel of Truth would be demolished, and it would be game over for them. As such, right now...

I will pay dearly if I act like a cheapskate in this situation.

Grit! Lloyd made a decision. With some struggle, he raised his body and opened his manaheart skill window.

[Skill Name: Manaheart.]

[Stage: High-Level Sword Expert Lv. 1]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 1,500%]

[Currently Owned Optional Skills: 1. Shock Neutralizer / 2. Complete Resistance to Poison / 3. Frenzy / 4. Half-Human Half-Dragon / 5. Time Freeze / 6. Swordmaster Syndrome]

[Required RP to level up: 2,000]

[Current RP: 23,534]

Let's give it a try.

Having decided, he selected the level-up button.

[You can invest a small portion of your RP to level up a skill.]

[Would you like to invest RP in your Manaheart Skill?]

[YES / NO]

Yes!

There was no time to be on the fence. He had to quickly level up as high as he could and help Javier out. Lloyd nodded.

Ding Dong!

[Skill Level Up!]

[Manaheart: High-Level Sword Expert Lv. 2]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 1,700%]

[Required RP to level up: 2,200]

[Current RP: 21,534]

Boom! His heart gave one big thump when his manaheart expanded. At the same time, everything around him suddenly grew clearer.

Hmph!

As his manaheart leveled up, his syndrome worsened. But Lloyd held on by clenching his teeth.

It has begun. I have to see it through to the end.

Right now, it was a do-or-die situation. He thus poured all of the RP he had to level up his manaheart skill. From level two to four... Then level five to six... From level eight to nine... But when he reached level ten, he found himself short on RP.

[Manaheart: High-Level Sword Expert Lv. 10]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 3,300%]

[Required RP to level up: 3,800]

[Current RP: 334]

“Tsk... I knew this would happen.” The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose bitterly. But since he had predicted this would happen already, it didn’t rattle him.

This isn’t my first time leveling up with RP. It’s just simple math. *I needed 2,000 RP to level up from level one to two. Then I needed 2,200 and 2,400 next. So, the required RP rose in increments of 200 for every level up.*

Lloyd could easily calculate the numbers while he poured his RP into the system, thanks to that.

I knew I’d lack 3,500 RP to reach the last level. Just like now.

And since he had predicted this, Lloyd had a solution for it as well.

This is how I will solve it!

Jumping to his feet, Lloyd suddenly yelled aloud enough for everyone to hear. “Everyone! Except for Javier and Draggy! Let’s evacuate to somewhere safe!”

SAFE! SAFE! SAFE!

He shouted at the top of his lungs, and his booming voice caused everyone to stop. Not missing the chance, Lloyd shouted once more.

“I like you all! Thank you! For fighting for me! I’m filled with gratitude! But you see! This isn’t a fight I want! Why?! I don’t want you all to get hurt because of me!”

Lloyd feared his vocal cords and eardrum would burst and shatter. His own shout sounded too loud in his head as his swordmaster syndrome was now at its peak. Instead of giving up, however, Lloyd flexed his legs and waist, stood at the top of the Jewel of Truth, and bawled louder so everyone could hear him even more clearly.

“You all were brought out here to work, not fight and get hurt! The White Cavalry! The engineers! Orc warriors and elf archers! Everyone! I don’t

want to see a single one of you get injured and die!”

He was sincere in his words. Everyone had come here to help construct the dam and the Jewel of Truth. He didn’t want them to be sacrificed in a battle they never planned to join. That would also be inefficient.

Duh. The angel is as strong as Javier, who’s a grandmaster. The White Cavalry? Orcs? Elves? Engineers? Regardless of their big number, they would hardly be any help. They’d just get hurt from joining in.

It’d only lead to unnecessary casualties. As such, he had to prevent that kind of disaster from happening.

“So, stay back! Evacuate to somewhere safe! I will protect you instead! I will go to the front and fight for you!” Lloyd shouted at the top of his lungs as if he were testing how long his lungs and vocal cords would hold out. This time, there were some lies mixed in between his sincere words. Furthermore, he put on a dramatic performance that he had planned in advance.

Everyone’s starting to get moved. Okay, the time is now. Here I go!

Ziiing! Lloyd rotated his mana circles, amplified a small portion of mana, and sent it to his right temple, where there was a bloody scab from being thrown on the ground. He sent the mana to the area behind his injury, causing his scab to pop.

With a popping sound like a cork being removed, the bloody scab was pushed out by the mana and widened until a stream of blood gushed out. It was also significantly more than he had expected.

All of a sudden, everyone was invited to a bloody fountain show. But Lloyd pretended to be all right even when his cheek was now wet with blood. He instead used it as a prop to make the situation more dramatic.

“I am all right!” yelled as he wiped his cheek with his hand. “Even if I’m beaten and hurt! Even if I have to give away my life! If it’s to protect you!

For the happiness and well-being of the fiefdom! For you! I'll sacrifice myself! And fight for each one of you!"

Lloyd's voice boomed across the sky. He then raised his shovel high as the final act of his dramatic performance. This set everyone's heart on fire.

"Waah!!!" everyone shouted, their voices sounding like a clap of thunder. And when they raised their fists up high, Lloyd saw messages he was glad to see.

Ding Dong!

[Your passionate and iron-will eloquence and actions stirred up strong emotions in everyone at the site!]

[Your likeability with Wrangler from the White Cavalry has increased by 1 point.]

[Orc Warrior Targa...]

[Elf archer Cayenne...]

[Engineering Corps Panamera...]

Ding Dong! Ding Dong Dong! Ding Dong!

His likeability with countless individuals went into a frenzy. As a result, Lloyd earned a massive amount of RP, much more than he needed.

[Current RP: 4,612]

This is what I'm talking about. Haha! Every little bit helps!

Lloyd clenched his fists and opened the system window. Now, he had enough. At last, the time had come for him to become a swordmaster.

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Chapter 322: Attack Design Skill (1)

Haha! Every little bit helps!

Lloyd clenched his fists and opened the system window. He had more than enough RP to level up.

[You are leveling up your manaheart to a higher rank.]

[Required RP to level up: 3,800]

[Current RP: 4,612]

[Proceed and level up the skill?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a yes.

Since it wasn't the time to be stingy about RP, he didn't think twice about selecting "YES".

Ding Dong!

[Skill Class Level Up!]

[Skill Name: Manaheart]

[Stage: Novice Swordmaster Lv. 1]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 4,000%]

[Currently Owned Optional Skills: 1. Shock Neutralizer / 2. Complete Resistance to Poison / 3. Frenzy / 4. Half-Human Half-Dragon / 5. Time Freeze]

[Required RP to level up: 10,000]

[Current RP: 812]

[Your Manaheart skill level has risen to the rank of <Novice Swordmaster>.]

[Your manaheart has finally made a huge jump through your innumerable hours of training until now and has risen to an impressive rank of sword mastery. This special and successful experience brought about a change to your manaheart skill.]

Messages restlessly flooded Lloyd's eyes. He couldn't afford to skip over a single message, especially the one informing him of a new optional skill.

[An optional skill has been removed.]

[Skill Option 6: Swordmaster Syndrome has been removed.]

[You have now become a swordmaster, which means you have full control over your heightened senses.]

Finally, the shackles that had been restraining him were now gone. Instead, he obtained a pair of wings that would take him to new heights.

Ding Dong!

[A new optional skill has been added.]

[You have become one of the most notable swordmasters in Lorasian history. Moreover, you are the first person to reach this level through a method that hadn't existed before now. Your unique process of growth and success has greatly affected your skill set. Accordingly, you will be receiving a large reward.]

[One of the skills you own will be randomly merged with your manaheart skill to create a combined optional skill.]

A combined optional skill? Linked to another skill?

What could it be? Lloyd carefully looked at the message, and he immediately found the answer.

[Your converged optional skill has been registered in your manaheart skill.]

[Skill Option 6: Attack Design - After surveying your skill history, “Designing” was used the most aside from your manaheart skill. You have spent countless hours designing buildings, and this strenuous experience has been combined with your manaheart skill. From now on, you can design and put aside potential attacks of your opponents and yourself and the outcomes of those actions in advance to utilize at the present moment.]

[For more information, please select the “more information” button below.]

What the? I can design my attacks?

Lloyd gulped dryly. He knew from one quick glance at the message that this new skill was going to be something special.

More information.

He pressed the button below, and more information cascaded down immediately.

[Skill Option 6: Attack Design]

[More Information (1): Attack Design is an optional skill that allows you to design your and someone else’s actions in advance and apply it in real life.]

[More Information (2): You can transfer the data you collected with your surveying skill regarding an individual’s physique, weight, etc., into the virtual design space.]

[More Information (3): You can manipulate and design the spatial location, posture, order of movement, weight transfer, etc of the figure in the design space. However, you cannot design movements that are physically impossible to do for the individual that is being modeled.]

[More Information (4): You can transfer your own data into the design space and freely design your location, action, attack route, speed, strength, and striking point. However, just as in information (3), you cannot design movements that are physically impossible to do with your body.]

[More Information (5): You can also save “combination” that combines you and your object’s actions you had designed in your design space.]

[More Information (6): Once you finish using the design space, the collected data can be saved and applied in real life at any time.]

[More Information (7): The save capacity for the attack design space is three. However, it can be expanded by leveling up your optional skill.]

[More Information (8): The subject of design is limited to one.]

[More Information (9): The length of time for the movement you design is limited to five seconds.]

[More Information (10): Designing movements and collecting data does not cost anything. However, executing the collected data in real life consumes 250 RP for every try.]

Lloyd gleaned the information, forgetting to breathe as he did. His fists balled up and clenched on their own. That was how incredible this optional skill was. He could tell the moment he read it.

This is nuts! Completely mad!

This optional skill allowed him to design movements and put them aside to use in real life.

So, that means I can exert full control over someone for five seconds.

Five seconds. Sure, it was a short amount of time, but in a desperate and urgent situation, this was more than enough. Plus, the optional skill had more to offer beyond that.

I can even design movements for myself. This means that I can coordinate my moves to align with the ones I design for others. In that case, I can use the skill similar to how movie stars coordinate their moves with stunt doubles before shooting an action scene.

The exciting stunt scenes on TV, which looked incredible and impressive inside movies, looked ugly and messy in real life. The actors looked more like a group of emotional teenagers trying to punch one another. Real life wasn't carefully orchestrated like films, and the same was true with sword fighting. Using controlled and elaborate sword movements to combat and block your opponent was nearly impossible to do unless you were on the same level as Javier or Queen Alicia. It went without saying that Lloyd couldn't do it.

Not even worth thinking about.

That was the reality. That is, up until this moment. Now...

It's a completely different story.

Lloyd was convinced as he looked at his new skill. Five seconds. He held complete control over someone for that time period. He could manipulate someone's body, design an attack to use on them, and bring it all to life. The skill, however, wasn't his only reward.

Thump! Thump—!

His heart was racing. No, it was his manaheart. It was on a rampage as it spread a strong vibration and pounding sensation to his heart, muscles, tendons, bones, skin, internal organs, arteries, and capillaries, pumping him with a new sense of invigoration.

This stormy sensation, the flooding charge of power... All of these belonged to him. The expanded and controlled sensation of the sword master paved a whole new world before him. When he lifted his gaze, he realized that swordmaster syndrome was a joke compared to the actual experience of being a swordmaster.

I see it. I see everything.

His gaze moved down to the fierce battle between Javier and Raphael below, and his eyes were able to catch all of their movement. He wasn't at the same level as a grandmaster or high-ranking angel yet. But he was able to get a vague read of their moves. That was particularly true for Raphael.

Now, I can see it. Javier is at least two times better than him in terms of the rapidity, precision, and variety of moves. But Raphael is... strong. Much stronger than Javier.

A thought crossed Lloyd's mind as he watched the fight. Maybe all the angels were high-end punching bags in their past lives. Raphael, literally speaking, was outrageously strong. The small blows from the two's stormy exchange of offense and defense had a minimal effect thanks to Raphael's incredible resilience and restorative ability. He attacked. Then got hit again. Yet, he continued to endure everything thrown at him and push back.

To compare them to animals... Javier is a weasel with fatal offense capabilities, while Raphael is...a strong wild boar from the rough mountains. There's only one way to end this fight. It's to overpower the boar with a fierce punch.

That was what Javier was failing to do at the moment. It wasn't that he lacked the strength. It was that there hadn't been an opportunity for him to throw his final blow.

Raphael's fighting skills are nothing to look down on after all. He's allowing Javier's smaller blows to land on him and dodging all the bigger ones. What a troublesome opponent he is. Well then. Time to create a momentary slip in his defense. Survey!

Lloyd activated his surveying skill.

[Scanning will begin.]

Bzzt! Lloyd's sword master senses scanned Raphael's moves and his physique. Once he turned it into a set of data points, he uploaded the

information into the virtual data space.

[You are uploading the surveyed subject, “Raphael the Throne” into the design space.]

[Manaheart Skill Option 6: You can freely control the surveyed subject’s movements.]

[Would you like to activate the Attack Design mode?]

[YES / NO]

Why else would I survey him? Yes!

The space for the Attack Design appeared in his view. Raphael floated in the air, and Lloyd’s hands moved faster as they got to work.

Okay. How should I deal with him? Like this. This way. That way.

Swish! Swish! Lloyd coordinated a string of moves for Raphael to follow in his virtual space. There wasn’t much to do since the moves had to take less than five seconds to complete. Next, he designed his own attack before saving his work.

[Please name the design that will be saved in slot 1.]

Space Out!

[Slot 1 has been saved as “Space Out.”]

Lloyd wasn’t satisfied yet.

While I’m at it, I should fill up all the slots!

Attentively designing more sequences of movements and attacks, Lloyd rushed to use the rest of his slots and quickly set it all aside for later.

[Slot 2 has been saved. “Bent Leg Twist.”]

[Slot 3 has been saved. “Thwack.”]

[You have filled all three slots.]

[You must delete an existing slot to save a new Attack Design in the system.]

Okay. It’s done.

Lloyd clenched his fists now that everything was all set. He then jumped off the Jewel of the Truth peak with a shovel in his grip, and as he jumped off the stairs, Lloyd rotated his three-strand mana circle and thrust his shovel forward just in time to fire a triple mana blast at Raphael.

Kaboom! The burst of mana jetted from his shovel to engulf Raphael and finish him. But the same attack that had once penetrated the Gigatitan’s body was neutralized when Raphael casually deflected it with his free hand.

Boom! Lloyd, however, wasn’t disappointed even though his blast disappeared into the sky.

That was just a greeting.

The real fight started now. Raphael may have put up a good fight against Javier and troubled the latter with his incredible strength. But now, he was nothing but a toy at Lloyd’s disposal.

See how I do it.

Lloyd then made a landing right in the middle of the fight. He found Raphael towering over himself when he lifted his gaze. He also noticed Javier coming to save him in surprise. Disregarding them both, Lloyd activated his Attack Design skill.

Ding Dong!

[Manaheart Skill Option 6: Activating Attack Design.]

[Please select the slot of data you saved.]

Space Out!

Lloyd shouted inwardly as if he waited for his skill to activate. The response was immediate.

[Uploading data for “Space Out”.]

[You have used 250 RP for the skill.]

[Current RP: 562]

A message appeared in the corner of his vision. Even then, the situation was developing at a breathless pace.

“Master Lloyd!” Javier yelled frantically from behind.

Despite Raphael’s iron mace, which was ready to strike Lloyd in the head, Lloyd stayed still and didn’t move an inch. Despite Raphael’s ghastly energy and Javier’s frantic efforts to protect him, Lloyd merely cast a cool and confident gaze at Raphael.

[“Space Out” data has been actualized in real life.]

When the message appeared...

Thud! The iron mace suddenly dropped to the ground with a sound. And then, Raphael slumped forward and took on a dazed posture.

“Eh...?” A dull sound came out of Raphael’s mouth.

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Chapter 323: Attack Design Skill (2)

“Eh...?”

A dull sound spilled out of Raphael’s mouth. It wasn’t intentional. He was startled.

What’s happening to my body?

All of a sudden, out of the blue, a mysterious force drained Raphael’s strength. His arms drooped on their own, and his neck craned forward while his back curled into a ball. His knees gave way and buckled.

What on earth is this?

Raphael’s heart raced in sheer panic. This was bad. This couldn’t be happening. He was in the middle of his important task from heaven to punish those obstructing justice.

Why did I let go of my mace? Argh! Ugh!

Raphael tried to bend lower to pick up his mace and subdue the two humans in front of him, Lloyd and Javier. But his body froze and refused to obey his brain.

What is happening?

The moment he tried to overcome his dismay and confusion, Raphael heard Lloyd Frontera speak.

“Hey! Step on him!”

Thwack!

A shot of pain rushed up his ankle. Just then, everything around him shook. His body collapsed.

Hmm?

Suddenly, the world turned upside down, and Raphael noticed his own two feet up in the air. It was followed by a pang of pain at the back of his head.

A shovel? Did he hit my ankle with that?

Right before he fell flat on the ground, Raphael saw a glimpse of the shovel in Lloyd's hand. That was when he was able to make out what had happened. It looked like Lloyd indeed hit his ankle with a shovel.

Unbelievable. That's how I lost balance? What's going on?

Thud! It didn't hurt much when the back of his head hit the ground from his fall. He accidentally bit his tongue, but it hardly left any real damage to his sturdy physique.

Like this can hurt me!

Provoked and ashamed that he collapsed from being attacked by a human's shovel, Raphael tried to get back to his feet. But he found the task impossible to achieve.

Hmm?

For a split second, Raphael's brain froze. He knew what he had to do. Get back to his feet. Punish these despicable humans. But his body refused to budge.

Why?!

Raphael screamed inwardly, but it was useless. His desperate mind was betrayed by his oblivious body slumping down in a lifeless state.

Why? Why is this happening? Arggh! Come on!

Thwack! Thwack! Clang! Then, there came several blows towards Raphael.

Ack! Argh!

Raphael's frantic effort eventually allowed his eyes to roll sideways.

There was Lloyd, beaming as he swung his shovel by its side without stopping in a rhythmic motion, as though he was playing a game of Catch a Mole.

“Hey! What are you doing? I said, trample him!”

A new look came over Javier’s eyes at Lloyd’s shout. That was when Raphael’s heart finally started to sink.

Lloyd’s shovel strikes didn’t do much damage. But a grandmaster’s attacks? That would be a completely different story.

I can’t let him hit me!

Feeling another rush of frantic urge to move, Raphael used all his focus to squeeze out every bit of his strength from his body, which finally freed him from a limp state.

“Argh!”

A gigantic sword immediately came down on the very spot where Raphael lay down a second ago.

CLANG!

Thousands of aura strands rummaged through and tore apart the area. If Raphael was even a tenth of a second late, his upper torso would have been engulfed by the aura storm. The thought sent a chill down his spine.

Auras are dangerous.

There was only one form of attack in this realm that could damage his angelic body. An aura.

Since auras are crystallized forms of pure mana, they can leave direct damage on my body which is made of spiritual powers. Moreover, this grandmaster’s aura is... particularly more dangerous.

He was overpowered earlier with another attack, but this was much more dangerous. If he was hit now, he'd be neutralized for good. Which meant...

I'd fail my duty. I can't let that happen.

The accomplishments he had achieved to this day and his future of serving the heavenly realm and the world. Everything would go down the drain. Raphael wasn't going to let that happen.

Ackkk!

Resolved, Raphael immediately turned and rolled over, picking up his iron mace as he did before springing back up and raising his weapon to defend himself against Javier's attack. Their collision produced raging shock waves all around them. Breaking the shock waves, Raphael hurtled toward Javier.

Thud! Twang! Twang! Thud! Raphael swung, stabbed, slashed, struck, and slammed down his mace. But Javier brilliantly parried and received every attack he received, replicating the same scene that everyone had seen countless times until now. Lloyd, who was also watching the scene, smiled, the corners of his mouth going up to his ears.

Great. Just perfect. The Attack Design is much more useful than I expected.

Lloyd recalled what happened a few seconds ago. He wasn't completely confident beforehand, but the attack design skill was perfectly able to apply itself in a real fight.

The design I saved in slot 1 forced its subject to stand still in a dazed state.

Since it was his first attempt, Lloyd figured he should first start with a simple move. He aimed to create the simplest and most effective design possible. That ended up being to make Raphael take on a dazed posture.

The movement design was accurately carried out. Just like my design, Raphael dropped the mace and became defenseless.

There was more. The offensive attacks he included were just as accurately executed.

The part where Raphael was to fall down after I struck his ankle with a shovel and then receive a blow from the ground by me again went exactly as envisioned. But one disappointing thing was that Javier reacted slightly late.

Lloyd had hoped that Javier would immediately join in and trample Raphael. But that didn't happen as Javier raised his sword right when the five-second time limit passed. This, however, wasn't a problem for Lloyd.

I've got two more data slots!

Lloyd then sneakily moved behind Javier, taking advantage of Raphael's tendency to ignore him and focus only on the latter. It was also the safest spot from the angel's attacks and their resulting shock waves.

"Hey, Javier," said Lloyd after settling down at the safe spot, "Why didn't you listen to me back there?"

"Master Lloyd? What do you mean?"

Clang! Clang! Clang! Twang! Thud! Amid the countless exchange of attacks, Javier quickly cast a glance toward Lloyd and asked, "I have a question for you, Young Master. What in the earth did you do back there?"

"Do what?" innocently asked Lloyd.

"The angel stopped attacking the moment you laid your eyes on him."

"Oh, and?"

"You attacked him right afterward as if you had been waiting for that to happen."

"Did that look strange to you?"

"Yes." Javier briefly nodded. "I cannot erase the feeling that you were waiting for something specific to happen."

“Feeling, my foot.” Lloyd chuckled off. “I’m not some sort of divine entity that can predict an angel’s moves. Does that make any sense to you?”

“...”

“The bastard just got distracted in the middle of the fight,” Lloyd insisted.

“Are you sure?”

“Obviously,” huffed Lloyd. “Look at him even now. He’s busy rushing forward to attack you no matter how much I stare at him.”

Booom! Clang! Clang! Clang! Clang!

Lloyd was right. Even during their current conversation, Javier had to concentrate all of his focus on fighting Raphael. That was how fierce and ferocious the angel’s attacks were.

But something was strange before.

Javier soon concluded that there was no way to prove Lloyd wrong. After all, it wasn’t like Lloyd possessed any sort of extraordinary power that would let him subdue a high-ranking angel with just his gaze. Raphael, who was listening to their conversation, had the same thought.

Argh... I knew that was the case.

Raphael frowned as he wielded his iron mace to neutralize Javier’s defense, emitting rays of light with his wings and scolding himself at the same time.

Yes. That human, Lloyd Frontera, was right. There is no way I fell for a trap from a lowly mortal and ended up in such a pathetic state.

Come to think of it, that really was the case. Be toyed by that human? Ridiculous and impossible. So, there was only one conclusion he could draw.

I lowered my guard.

Raphael concluded that he had unconsciously lowered his guard because he was up against a few lowly humans and got distracted in the middle of their fight.

Tsk! I was too relaxed. I became unconscionably arrogant because of my continued success thus far. This won't do. I'll take this as a painful lesson for myself and reflect on my mistakes. I can't behave so stupidly again.

Clench! Raphael gritted his teeth with a penitent heart and gripped the iron mace, feeling a sudden rush of adamant resolution. But it didn't last long. Just a second later, when he locked eyes with Lloyd, it happened again.

Bent Leg Twist!

Ding Dong!

[Manaheart Skill Option 6: Activating Attack Design.]

[Uploading the data for "Bent Leg Twist".]

[You have used 250 RP to activate the skill.]

[Current RP: 321]

Eh...?

The moment Raphael sensed that something was off and a chill ran down his spine, a new message appeared in front of Lloyd.

[The data for "Space Out" has been applied to real life.]

Just then.

"Eh? Eh? Eh?"

Leap! Propelled by a mysterious force, his body was thrown to the ground, and his arms spread apart while his legs rose to a 45-degree angle. This naturally caused his abs to tense. Eventually, Raphael suddenly found himself in a posture utterly unsuitable for combat.

Hahaha! How do you like that? One of the physical training postures! Bent Leg Twist!

Lloyd's lips curved into a villainous smile. This time, as well, his attack design was effective.

"Hey!" bellowed Lloyd. "Trample on him properly this time!"

Lloyd pointed at Raphael with his shovel. This time, Javier didn't disappoint him. As soon as Raphael lay on the ground, Javier immediately held up his sword.

I knew it. This was his doing.

Javier was certain about it despite Lloyd's denial. There was no other way to explain Raphael's eccentric behavior. It couldn't have been that the angel had lowered the guard. He had undoubtedly fallen into a trap set by Lloyd. But it didn't matter to Javier.

I can't miss this opportunity!

Fwoosh! Javier brandished his sword, slashing down the air and ravaging Raphael who was lying down in a strange posture.

Slaaash!

"Gargh!" Raphael screamed aloud, totally exposed to the blow. Unable to put up any defense, he could only accept Javier's attack while positioned flat on the ground.

Gargh...! Ha...

He was in despair. It felt like his whole body was being ripped into atomic particles.

I cannot... lose like this!

Raphael clenched his teeth, extracting all of the divine spirit inside his body and amplifying the holy power he attained by absorbing the angelic ring to

its maximum capacity. He invested every bit of his strength to defend the aura storm attacking him. Then he prayed for greater strength, the will to endure this hardship, and for the support of the great heavens. At last, his body returned to normal after five.

Cough! Cough! “Argh!”

Am I alive? Raphael wondered as he struggled to sit up, propping his hands against the ground while his legs were glued to the ground. He repeated in his head that he had to wake up and guided by a will that he couldn’t make out to be his own or the heavens, Raphael crawled forward. His eyes burned with passion.

I refuse to collapse. I refuse to be overpowered by a mortal human. I refuse to face defeat just like this!

But when he lifted his head, he noticed the shovel coming for his forehead.

How dare he! With a shovel!

Raphael tensed his forehead, thinking how absurd the human was for trying to injure him with a mere, auraless piece of metal. He would easily be able to hold out against it. After enduring its attack, he just needed to raise his body, stall for time, and recover from the damage he had received.

This is doable. I can quickly recover and fight again. Even if that knight is a grandmaster, he’ll get tired soon. Victory will be mine in the end. I will complete my mission!

Raphael yelled inwardly. He had come to a decision. But there was something Raphael was ignorant of. It was that this whole scenario where he was positioned to defend himself against Lloyd’s shovel attack was based on the human’s attack design.

A brilliant aura suddenly appeared at the shovel as it flew forward for the final blow, a blow that’d spark passionate conflict between Lloyd’s fiefdom and heaven. *Thwack!*

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Chapter 324: The Throne Angel in the Guest Chamber (1)

Thwack!

A bell tolled in Raphael's head. To whom was this bell tolling? He wondered. Was it for himself who ended his first failed mission? Or for the lowly human who fiercely fought him? Or for the mundane world that would soon descend into chaos from breaking the order of Heaven?

It's funny.

Raphael found himself bursting into laughter. There was no way to explain his collapsed state, how he ended up in this condition, nor what caused him to fail his mission so tragically.

I need to stand...

But Raphael was out of energy. Drained. He had emptied all the energy he acquired by absorbing his ring.

I was undeniably defeated.

He had thought about when his first failure would occur. But he never even imagined it would involve a mere human who used a shovel as a weapon. That part was the most ridiculous part to him.

"Ha. Haha... Ha." Amid his fading vision, Raphael turned to the side and found Lloyd looking down at him. "Lloyd... Frontera... Do you really insist on killing me and treading the path of evil?"

"No," drawled Lloyd." I'm not going to do that."

Raphael stared at Lloyd.

"Why would I tread the path of evil from here?" The corners of his lips rose a little.

"..."

“That’s one serious and ridiculous question.”

Raphael continued listening.

Lloyd went on, “I don’t have any plans to kill or put an end to you. I’m worried about what would happen afterward if I do that. Come on, please just let us have a discussion. That is, before you pass out.”

“What now...” Raphael blinked hard, the eyelids feeling heavy. He couldn’t understand what this human wanted if his plan wasn’t to kill him and tread the path of evil. “Talk about... What...?”

“I would like to talk about who’s liable for this ridiculous situation and the cause behind it.”

Lloyd chuckled as he flopped on the ground at Raphael’s side. “I made it clear to you a while ago, do you remember? I don’t want to get into a conflict with you. However, you proceeded to attack me first, and that’s why this happened. Wouldn’t you agree?”

“That doesn’t make any-”

“Doesn’t make any sense?” put in Lloyd irritably. “It’s the undeniable truth and fact of the matter. Tell me, did I attack you first? No, right? You started talking about the obstruction of justice or whatever it was and then attacked me. Am I wrong?”

Raphael refused to talk. He only blinked.

“Haa…” Lloyd flared his nose. “You really know how to push my buttons. I’ll give you that. Here’s what happened. You appeared out of the blue to demolish the Jewel of Truth. When I resisted, you threatened to kill me by smashing my head with that absurd-looking iron mace over there.”

“...”

“Let me ask you one thing,” continued Lloyd. “Is the heavenly realm made up of thugs?”

“Of course not,” defended Raphael indignantly.

“Then why did you do it?”

“Well, for the good of the public-”

“Good of the public?” Lloyd raised his voice. “What good?”

Speaking ever so slowly and heavily, Raphael began to present his case. “It was a decision to maintain order in Heaven and this world, as well as for the best interest of the public,” Raphael spoke without hesitation. Even though he was losing strength and fading deeper into unconsciousness with every passing second, his voice sounded completely firm. “It is a banned structure. I mean, the Jewel of Truth. The heavens have forbid it from being built in this realm... due to its potential to reveal dangerous secrets. That’s why it can’t be built here… That was the final decision, so it’s only right for the jewel to be demolished.”

“It’s not right,” Lloyd opposed curtly after listening to Raphael’s argument.

“Excuse me?”

Lloyd noticed a slight flutter of surprise in Raphael’s eyes. “Why is it right?”

“What kind of drivel are you talking-”

“Excuse me,” Lloyd said as he raised a finger at Raphael. “Mister Angel. Drivel? Do you even hear yourself? For the good of the public? To maintain order? That’s why it was not authorized for construction? Who made this decision?”

“Well, of course, the heavenly realm—”

“Okay, so those gentlemen up there. Did they come down here and even try having a single conversation with us?”

“That is...” Raphael broke off.

“No, right? So, what do you mean by for the good of the public? You all unilaterally made a decision, came to a conclusion, and determined what would happen next. And then, boom! You came down like a bolt of lightning and ordered us to accept your decision because it came from the heavens. Can you really say that behavior aligns with public interest and order? Come on now.”

“...”

“Think about it from our perspective,” went on Lloyd. “It’s irritating. It feels like I’ve been given the middle finger after all the work I poured into building the jewel. Did you even stop to consider that?” By now, the confidence in his voice started to sound more emotional and irritable. “Seriously, I’m getting more pissed from talking about this. Look now. Is this how you always did your job? This duty of yours as a public official. Was it always carried out this way?”

“That is...” Raphael stopped short before finishing his sentence.

“I’m right. That’s exactly how it is. You’ve always carried out your work like this,” Lloyd continued. “Please answer honestly, Mister Angel. Have you ever bothered to listen to the people impacted by your work? I’m sure you never even allowed them to give their input.”

Despite Lloyd’s accusation, Raphael had nothing to say.

“I’m asking if you ever thought things from other people’s perspectives.”

Raphael clamped his mouth shut. He wanted to defend himself against the human who had dared to argue with an angel. But somehow, his mouth remained shut tight and refused to budge. Meanwhile, Lloyd continued to speak.

“Did I say anything wrong? I didn’t. That’s why you have nothing to say. You’ve always looked down at us from Heaven in the sky, made decisions without any outside input, and forced orders on us. That’s how it’s been until now. Without exception. Please do correct me if I’m wrong.”

“...”

“I’ll ask you one more time.” Lloyd paused a second. “Do your actions really uphold public interest and order?”

“O-Of course-”

“It upholds the public interest and order of your realm,” Lloyd completed Raphael’s sentence.

Raphael was speechless. Lloyd’s words left no room for argument. In his silence and fading consciousness, Raphael looked back on his past and his countless successes in completing his duties as a public official. Upon reflection, something became crystal clear.

What that human said isn’t wrong.

In hindsight, the human’s words were right. He had never bothered to hear the opinions of those impacted by his work during the countless years he spent dealing with an even greater amount of civil complaints. He never considered or asked for their perspective.

I’ve merely been a robot that mindlessly completes tasks and follows orders from my superiors.

Was that really to promote public interest? To maintain order? Perhaps Lloyd was right, Raphael thought. He was only upholding the public interest and order of his realm.

“I...”

I don’t know. I really don’t know, Raphael thought. Raphael didn’t know what to say. Why his heart suddenly felt bitter. Everything was a blur now. With that final thought, he lost consciousness. Raphael the Thrones. An icon who achieved rapid career advancement and historic success. This marked his first failure and coma.

***

Coma. Dizziness. *Where am I? Why am I lying down? And why do I feel comfortable right now?*

Raphael slightly opened his eyes, and the light blinded his vision. But it wasn't sunlight in his eyes.

It's back. My rings of fire.

The two rings floated over his body and were burning with holy fire as they did before. They were warm and reliable, ready to protect him at any time. Raphael felt relieved at this sight.

What a relief. I thought I'd permanently lost them.

Raphael suddenly recalled how he used a curse word for the first time in his life. Consequently, he defiled his purity and lost his rings of fire. But now that the fire was back, he figured that his impure heart had been completely cleansed once again.

Hold on. What about the human?

Raphael shuddered when he started to regain his memories of what he experienced bit by bit.

I was about to demolish the Jewel of Truth, but someone interrupted me... And when I tried to punish Lloyd Frontera...

He had been defeated. By being struck in the forehead with a shovel. His first loss. He had even fainted!

Raphael bolted upright in bed at the frightening memory, dropping the white blanket covering his body to the side. This shocked Lloyd, who was sleeping beside the bed.

"Hmph? Ugh, you surprised me," muttered Lloyd as he wiped his lips.

"..."

"Oh, I must have dozed off. That is, while nursing you."

Raphael simply stared without saying anything.

“I am telling the truth. I’m not sure if you know, but I’ve been suffering from terrible insomnia lately. Haah. Yet, I still fought against my fatigue and nursed you. Doesn’t that make you feel touched?” Lloyd yawned as he stretched his arms.

“You nursed me?”

“Yes.” Lloyd chuckled as he wiped off the sleep from his eyes. “I’m serious. You slept like a baby after you passed out.”

“Yesterday?”

“Yes. It was yesterday when we got into a bloody fight against each other.”

“And you chose not to kill me?”

“Why would I do that?” Lloyd shrugged. “To be honest, my knight wanted to do just that, seeing how dangerous you are. He said that you might attack us again. But, well, as you can see, I’m a generous man.”

Raphael cast an alarmed look.

“Ha...” sighed Lloyd dramatically. “I can genuinely say that I have a generous heart. Up until yesterday, you were swinging mace all around and trying to destroy years’ worth of my work. But here you are, in my guest’s bedroom, being nursed by me while I fight against my fatigue. Ahh, I should actually charge you a lodging and medical fee, you know.”

Raphael merely continued to stare at Lloyd, feeling slightly dazed. Listening to this man’s chattering, it became clear.

I was truly defeated.

But it looked like the man had forgiven him. Raphael knew that the human had plenty of time to kill him while he was out for an entire day. But Lloyd didn’t do that and took care of him instead.

“Then,” Raphael found himself speaking up. “I will stay here for a while.”

“Eh?” Lloyd softly jerked back in surprise.

“I mean, instead of returning to Heaven, I’d like to stay in your fiefdom for around ten years.”

“Wait, hold on—”

“Yes?”

“I’m saying out loud that I need to charge you, and yet, you announce that you will stay here for ten years? Mister Angel, where are your manners? Were you some sort of thug in Heaven?”

“No.” Raphael found himself grinning. After organizing his thoughts, he added, “Even if I want to go back now, it is impossible. I lost my halo.”

“Halo?” asked Lloyd. “Oh, you mean the ring on your head?”

“Yes. An angel can’t enter Heaven without it. It’s like a travel pass.”

“Then-”

“Don’t worry too much,” put in Raphael. “It’ll re-appear on its own after ten years.”

“Isn’t ten years too much time?”

‘‘To angels, ten years is equivalent to a period of one month for humans.”

“You know a decade is considered a very long period of time here, right?”

“I will be all right. I am an angel.” Raphael smiled gently as if he was doing Lloyd a favor.

“No,” said Lloyd, almost chuckling. “I’m saying this because it’s not okay for us.”

Lloyd gave Raphael a dumbstruck look.

What the heck? What? Why is he trying to leech off us now?

But even before Lloyd could give a flat rejection, Raphael spoke first. “To be honest, it’s because of the advice I heard from you yesterday.”

“Eh?”

“The piece of advice you gave me before I passed out.”

“Advice...” Lloyd searched for his memory.

“You told me yourself about how we angels carry out our duties…and that we never consider anyone else’s perspective when making a decision. That we never think about those who are impacted by our work.”

Lloyd remembered.

“I wanted to deny your words when I first heard it,” went on Raphael, “But when I thought over them, you had a point. It made me look back on my work.” A remorseful smile suddenly appeared on Raphael’s mouth. “It was a shocking revelation. I always thought I was helping the world, but I realized it could’ve been for my self-righteousness and pride all along. As such, I plan to reflect on what to do from here, what attitude I should have while carrying out my duties, and what I will do if I have a disagreement with my supervisors during this process.”

“Oh, so you want to stay here to heal and think over your concerns for free?”

“Yes, I don’t know what answers I will find, but I have around ten years to organize my thoughts.”

“Um... You know I didn’t permit you to stay yet.”

“Then, are you going to kick me out?”

“That depends on how you will be able to help us,” casually answered Lloyd.

Obviously! I’m not going to take in a useless leech! My house isn’t a homeless shelter!

As such, Raphael would have to pay for his meals and prove his worth. This went without saying out loud.

Even Dragon King Verkis, who seems to be doing nothing all day, is contributing in his own way. He’s my sponsor in any case.

And here was Raphael, an angel with nowhere to go, declaring he would stay in his fiefdom for free. There was no way Lloyd would approve of this senseless announcement. Lloyd shot a deathly glare at Raphael, who flinched. It was the angel’s first time receiving this unfamiliar gaze with such an oppressive force coming from it.

Unaware that the prickling guilt in his heart was due to the pressure Lloyd put on him, Raphael finally made a promise and gave what the other wanted in return. “Well, if you let me stay here, then I will...”

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Chapter 325: The Throne Angel in the Guest Chamber (2)

“Um, well, if you let me stay here, then I will... provide you with news from Heaven. How does that sound?”

“Oh, news from your realm?” asked Lloyd. He was piqued.

“Ah, yes. Since I need to provide help for you to permit my stay here.”

“We’re off to a good start. Please elaborate on what you said. Ehem!”

Lloyd forced himself to cough so he could stop the corners of his mouth from rising. But he couldn’t stop his tongue from hula-dancing in his mouth.

Great. This is perfect.

Lloyd had a faint suspicion about the angel’s naivety. And as expected, his hunch was proven correct. Raphael had a pure heart that hadn’t been tainted by the evils of the human realm. He knew this by other man’s inclination to quickly give in to his demand with a petty attitude and just a little bit of pressure. Just like now.

“Elaborate?” said Raphael. “Hmm, what should I say? Even though I cannot return to Heaven because I lost my halo, it’s still possible for me to communicate with them to some extent. This is especially true as I hold a fairly important position.”

“Does that mean you can hear guidelines from your superiors?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes,” affirmed Raphael. “It’s something like that.”

“Then,” gulped Lloyd, “Does that mean you could inform me when any additional decisions or reactions come from the heavens regarding the Jewel of Truth?”

“I assume so.” Raphael nodded.

Suddenly, Lloyd became curious. Cocking his head to the side, he asked, “But are you okay doing so?”

“Come again?”

“Mister Angel, no, Raphael.”

“Yes?”

“The thing is, you are the angel from above with considerably high status. Are you sure it’s all right for you to provide me with intelligence on your realm?”

“Ah, yes,” replied Raphael, understanding what Lloyd was referring to. “Since my work was suspended the moment I lost my halo.”

Lloyd nodded. “Hmm...”

“I am simply informing you on the decisions made by the higher-ups, and it is up to you to decide how to use it. Moreover, they will likely not discourage me from doing so.”

“That is a relief on my part,” replied Lloyd. “But how can I trust you?”

“What... do you mean?”

“You could be feeding me false information on purpose.”

“Lying, you mean?”

“Yeah.” Lloyd nodded his head again. “You could pretend to be cooperative, only to demolish the Jewel of Truth behind my back.”

Raphael looked Lloyd in the eye. “That is not true. I have no plans of doing that.”

“And why is that?”

“Because of your words. It’s questionable to me whether the unilateral decision to demolish the Jewel of Truth without discussing the matter with you all was right... I’ve developed some doubts about it, you see.” Raphael smiled gently.

Raphael was speaking from his heart. A part of him obviously was crestfallen over the first failure of his career, but on the other hand, there was a sense of liberation in his heart to his surprise. He also came to perceive his occupational calling with a bit of resignation as it became plain to him that his success was wrongfully earned.

Pointing at his fiery ring, Raphael said, “I am born to only tell truths, not lies. I lose my purity the moment I lie. You have seen it. How the fire on my rings went off the moment I said a curse word.”

“Uh-huh.”

“If you are still doubtful, you can test me.”

“May I?”

“Of course.” There was confidence in Raphael’s voice.

Lloyd thought for a second before extending his hand out. “Okay. This is my hand. Is that right?”

“You are right.” Raphael’s answer, being truthful, didn’t extinguish the fire in his rings. Lloyd followed up with another question.

“On to the second test, then. The knight you went up against before. He is a good-looking man. Is that right?”

“I cannot agree with you more.” Raphael’s answer, which sounded very natural, didn’t extinguish the fire in his rings this time as well. Lloyd rushed to move on to the third question.

“Objectively speaking, I, too, am a man with a decently handsome appearance. Is that right?”

“You... are right.”

Puff. The fire on his rings was extinguished.

Suddenly, an air of embarrassment hung in the room. Tears welled up in Lloyd’s eyes.

A second later, the awkward silence was broken by Lloyd’s enraged shouting. “I think your rings are broken!”

“...”

“That’s right,” insisted Lloyd. “They’re broken. Those things are totally unreliable. Hahahaha!”

Raphael put on a pitying smile.

“Honestly, doesn’t it seem that the fire on your rings comes and goes just based on your mood, not purity? Right? That’s it. My, you spooked me for a second.”

“Excuse me, here.” Raphael was holding a handkerchief.

“What’s with the handkerchief?”

“I don’t know what you are thinking,” comforted Raphael. “But please wipe the tears off your face...”

Fwish! The fire in his rings returned. Larger drops of tears rolled down Lloyd’s cheeks. At last, he was forced to admit it. The angel’s rings of fire were working properly. There was no doubt that he could fully trust the information Raphael delivered to him.

Great. I’ve got exactly what I wanted.

Even though he was hurt by the unexpected truth bomb, Lloyd was quite satisfied with the deal he was able to squeeze out from Raphael, who planned to settle in his fiefdom for the next ten years.

The novel mentioned that the angels could communicate with the heavens in any situation they were in and receive instructions from their superiors. So, I thought that the most simple and effective way for Raphael to help me inside my fiefdom would be by keeping up with any updates from Heaven.

It was possible that receiving updates on what was happening inside Heaven in real-time and thus being able to prepare a response made this the most important piece of information for him to obtain in the present.

The construction of the Jewel will be completed soon.

He was moving into the final stage of the construction before being interrupted, anyhow. As such, with a little more effort, it'd be completed soon.

I'll use the jewel right away once it's finished being constructed.

He just needed to find out how to stop the restoration of destiny. And then what?

In the worst-case scenario, the heavens might issue a stricter measure. But I don't care. If the risks are too high, then I'll go and destroy the building myself. By then, I'll have received the solution to stop the restoration of destiny.

That was Lloyd's conclusion. All he needed was to construct the Jewel of Truth and find out how he could stop the restoration of destiny, and being updated on the situation in Heaven was critical to take action if they decided to push forward with the demolition. The chances of successfully stalling or resisting them only increased if he could plan ahead, and that was impossible without receiving intel. With that thought, Lloyd smiled with a glow of satisfaction.

"Whew, all right. You seem reliable enough."

"Is that so? Can I stay here, then?" asked Raphael joyfully.

“Yes, on the condition that you keep me updated in real-time on whatever is going on in Heaven.”

“I understand. Please take good care of me.”

“Haha, me too.” Lloyd flashed a big smile. “Okay, then, should we draw up a contract?”

“Excuse me...?”

Lloyd didn’t respond. He instead fished out two blank pages of paper.

Raphael tilted his head in confusion. “What’s that?”

“Can’t you tell? It’s a contract. A lease agreement.”

“...”

“Like everything else,” explained Lloyd, “Any promises or transactions should be recorded down in the form of contracts. That’s common sense. Maybe this isn’t the case in Heaven, but only the strongest make it out alive here.”

“...”

“So, to summarize what we’ve agreed to a moment ago...”

Lloyd’s aptitude for drawing up a contract allowed the whole process to be completed in no time. Raphael, flustered by the other man’s attitude, dazedly stamped the contract. Just like that, the lease agreement between the two opposing sides was signed and sealed.

***

Two days passed. During this time, the construction site was neatly organized after becoming a mess from the fight that ensued after Raphael’s arrival. There were quite a large number of workers, so the clean-up was able to be swiftly completed.

“Of course, there’s no time to take a break! Now, let’s get to work. The Skeleton Corps! Chant your slogan!”

“Overwork!”

“Burn the midnight oil!”

“Work until you die!”

The Skeleton Corps was put to backbreaking labor all throughout the day and night. They were completely fine with the schedule, even without any food or sleep. They were model laborers who believed that working overtime late into the night was the greatest virtue of all time.

I mean, of course. They like to rest and have fun too. But I’ve got to focus on the situation at hand.

The construction of the jewel had to be finished swiftly. Otherwise, the heavens could make another decision to demolish the Jewel of Truth right before its completion.

So, I have to hurry. It’s a speed war from now onward.

Lloyd made a firm resolution. The construction resumed the moment the final piece of trash was picked up. The remaining parts of the dam were put up nicely and solidly to endure any water pressure it would experience.

I can’t trap water inside it like a regular dam. So, I should do this.

This was the very reservoir where the Jewel of Truth would be operated, which meant that a huge tidal wave would occur.

It can’t hold up the wave by force.

Lloyd once did the math and concluded that the dam’s sturdiness alone wouldn’t be able to endure the force of the wave. As such, he decided to lower the center top area and create a sharp protrusion, the design being like a carton of milk with an open edge.

The sharp opening will minimize the water pressure and allow water waves to flow out.

Like how a milk carton spills the liquid through its pointy opening, the wave would trickle downstream from this hole when the Jewel of Truth was in operation.

I've done countless simulations already and completed all the inspections.

Lloyd was absolutely certain that it'd go as he intended. At the same time, he put his back into the final stage of the jewel construction. The architecture's facade looked exactly like the Tomb of the General, a large pyramid, and Corgidus was an immense source of help here.

"My goodness! You can't dig like that! Come on!"

Solitas, receiving tons of earfuls from Corgidus, continued to imprint decorations on the wall. Just like this, every process was done smoothly and swiftly. Lloyd's level of satisfaction increased day after day as he supervised the scene. At the same time, Javier's doubts toward Lloyd grew deeper as well.

"That is why I am telling you," Javier said, "I find you very suspicious."

"What?" What in the gibberish is this now? Lloyd frowned when he heard Javier speak in his usual icy voice as the two made their way home after a day of work. "Suspicious? What is?"

Could it be that Javier noticed that I'm not real? Lloyd asked himself. The twinge of guilt made his voice edgy. Javier, however, spoke in a calm voice.

"Your skills," replied Javier.

"My skills?"

"Yes."

Lloyd gulped. "What about them?"

“Up until a few months ago, you were barely able to become a high-level sword expert.”

“Oh, that?” Lloyd felt a swell of relief. “As expected, you realized it before I even told you.”

“Of course,” replied Javier. “I have seen the aura formed on the tip of your shovel.”

“You did? When I struck the angel on his head?”

“Yes, but that is not the only thing I saw.”

Lloyd became tense again. “What else did you see?”

“I also saw the angel’s unnatural movements, as if he was being manipulated by you.”

Lloyd decided to play ignorant. “Yeah, you’re delusional.”

Javier was offended by this. “I am not delusional.”

“You were mistaken,” huffed Lloyd. “What am I? Some sort of superhuman? A magician? And even if I’m one, you really think I could control no other than an angel?”

“Well...”

“No matter how you look at it, doesn’t that seem ridiculous?”

Javier suddenly realized Lloyd was right. “Indeed. In hindsight, I must have gone mad and overestimated your abilities.”

“...”

“Indeed. You are not capable of such things. Well, I supposed that the rank of a swordmaster isn’t difficult to get with some luck amidst an extremely pressing situation like fighting an angel.”

“...”

“But the ability to control an angel?” Javier coolly spoke. “I must have lost it for a second. I mean, who are you? You are merely Master Lloyd. Ha! Logic and common sense compel me to conclude that you are absolutely incapable of such a feat.”

“...”

“Um, but, Young Master.”

“What.”

“Why are you tearing up?”

“No, I’m not. My eyes are just shiny.”

“And your nose bridge is red.”

“I caught the flu.”

“Your lips are trembling too.”

“Must be my my nerves.”

“Why?”

“Because of you, my goodness. You put me down like this all day, every day. You’re a heartless monster.”

“I told you many times before, but I have never used violence against you, Master Lloyd.”

“Tsk, you are brazen.”

“That is your specialty, may I remind you.”

“That’s correct,” chuckled Lloyd. He was relieved. It looked like Javier didn’t cast too much suspicion on Lloyd’s extremely rapid growth and the

Attack Design skill used against Raphael.

I mean, I can feel that he thinks it's strange, but he's got no choice but to trust me. And the Attack Design is not easily detectable, so I can just pretend to be ignorant. But as for becoming a swordmaster in a few months... Tsk. Oh, well. I couldn't think of a better solution given the situation, so there's nothing I can do now even if he found it odd.

Lloyd concluded that he should just act shamelessly. He was about to present his shameless defense when...

"Fellow over there! Lloyd Frontera!"

It was Raphael flying with his wide-open wings from the Frontera manor.

"The news you have been waiting for! An update about the Jewel of Truth! An additional measure has been enacted by the heavens!" cried out Raphael as if he was announcing an urgent news.

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Chapter 326: You or Me (1)

“The news about the Jewel of Truth! An additional measure has been enacted!” Raphael landed on the ground as he folded his wings. His cheeks were slightly flushed.

"By that, do you mean a direct order has come from the heavens?" Lloyd inquired with delight. This was the news he had been waiting for. The reason he had let Raphael settle in his fiefdom.

“No,” Raphael said as he shook his head. “There has not been an official announcement yet. However...”

“What?” urged Lloyd.

“There have been rumors circulating among the Thrones angels about what additional measure the heavens will undertake.”

“Rumors circulating?” echoed Lloyd. “Are more angels coming down here?” He felt a pang of shock. One angel, Raphael, was enough to stir a commotion down here. But more Thrones angels were coming? Several of them?

I’ll never be able to stop them.

It would be the case even with Javier and his current self, who recently became a swordmaster. However, Raphael flashed an innocent smile and shook his head.

“Oh, there will not be more angels coming down from Heaven.”

“Then what is it?” asked Lloyd, feeling a swoosh of relief.

“A rainbow briefly appeared a while ago.”

“A rainbow?” Lloyd wondered where Raphael was going with this.

“Yes, a rainbow. That is what us angels use to exchange messages or information by displaying our writing on the stripe of color associated with our status.”

“Wait a minute,” mused Lloyd. “Like a group chat?”

Raphael cocked his head. “What’s a group chat?”

“Oh, never mind,” Lloyd said as he waved his hand. “Please go on and explain.”

“Yes. Seraphim uses the red stripe on the rainbow. Cherubim uses the orange stripe. Thrones, which I belong to, uses the yellow stripe. Principalities and everyone else use the purple stripe. All angels have the liberty to upload any thoughts or information they have in their rainbow stripe.”

“Okay,” observed Lloyd, “So, you saw a message appear in your group chat, I mean, the yellow stripe of the rainbow?”

“Yes. It mentioned my failure to demolish the Jewel of Truth and an additional measure that was enacted toward you and your building.”

“What did it say?” Lloyd gulped.

“They are going to summon you to Heaven.”

“What?” Lloyd felt shell-shocked. Then, with a heart full of fear, he asked, “Does that mean they’ll take me in?”

Raphael looked Lloyd in the eyes. “Yes, essentially.”

That made Lloyd gape in horror.

“But don’t worry,” Raphael assured after noticing how pale the other man was. “They won’t resort to savage methods as if they’re rounding up a criminal.”

“What will happen then?”

“It appears that the archangel wants to have a talk with you.”

“Talk with me...” This rather relieved Lloyd to a certain degree.

“I suppose he plans to make a judgment after hearing you out, given your fierce resistance to the demolition.”

“Hmm.” Lloyd looked at Raphael as if an idea came to him. “Then, I shouldn’t expect him to make a favorable decision for me in the end, right?”

“I’m sorry. I cannot predict that far ahead...” Raphael smiled apologetically.

“In that case, when will I be summoned? It’s not right now, is it?” Lloyd inwardly begged that he wouldn’t be taken away immediately. Thankfully, Raphael shook his head.

“No. There’s no way of knowing exactly when you will. Right now, it’s just a rumor going around the Thrones angels.”

“I guess then it’s not official yet?”

“You’re right.” Raphael nodded. “It isn’t.”

“But the official announcement will come soon?”

“Yes, perhaps. If things happen fast, it’ll be out within a month, and a group of Thrones or Dominion angels will come down.”

“Tsk.” Lloyd clicked his tongue. He knew that he wouldn’t be able to hold up against Thrones or Dominion angels.

Should I just be grateful that I’m not being immediately summoned? That means there’s only one way left for me.

A war of speed. Lloyd found his answer.

I won’t be able to reject the summoning. That will be true even with Javier and Draggy. My hands will be tied when a bunch of Raphael-level angels

show up. It’s smarter to just hasten things up and build the dam and the Jewel of Truth as soon as possible.

That appeared to be the best solution.

Since I'm in the final stages of construction already, I should finish and activate the building within a few days. I’ll then be able to find out how I can stop the restoration of destiny. That will do. After all, that was why I built the Jewel in the first place anyway.

Lloyd would be able to achieve that goal at the very least. And then?

Summon me or not. They can do whatever suits them.

Lloyd couldn't care less about being summoned and interrogated afterward at that point since he'd have already accomplished his goal. Furthermore, if Lloyd felt that the pressure from Heaven was too much to bear, he could simply accept their terms and give them whatever they wanted.

Still, it’s too much of a waste to throw the Jewel away, so I should first carefully listen to what they want before giving in to them. I likely won’t receive a harsh punishment then either. What more can they say if I agree with the demolition, after all?

This was the I've-got-nothing-to-lose-because-my-goal-was-met operation. Lloyd didn’t want to make even the smallest concession. He refused to live his life with that kind of attitude.

In this time and age, you’re a fool if you sit back and can’t take what’s yours.

Lloyd didn’t care if the others pointed their finger at him for being sly and deceitful. It was more important for him to claim what was his, and this time was no different.

I can’t fall behind. It’s a race against time from now on.

Now that Lloyd had learned of Heaven’s plan from Raphael, there wasn’t any time for him to waste. Lloyd put everything he had into finishing the

construction of the dam and the Jewel of Truth while also devising a proper response to Heaven’s decision.

The dam is almost finished. I’m glad that almost everything in the design could be perfectly executed.

As a result, the dam seemed to be far more effective in resisting external pressure than he originally expected it to be. Despite his success, however, Lloyd did not finish the project halfheartedly.

Maintaining the dam is more important than constructing it.

Lloyd put in extra effort during the final stages of construction, keeping in mind the need for long-term management and maintenance of the dam. He evaluated everything, including the water pressure, earth pressure, vertical subsidence, horizontal displacement, shear displacement, and positive pressure acting on the dam. He also calculated the potential stress that might occur on the structure from the expansion and shrinkage of concrete and checked to see if the dam had sunk during construction. Aside from all of this, Lloyd constructed a spillway for water to pass during emergencies and installed thick wire fences in the spot where any excess water from the dam would flow out.

These fences will filter any twigs and floating sediments that come upstream and clear the pathway for water to spill out of the dam.

Because it was such a large dam, there were numerous elements to inspect and touch up, even in the final stages of construction. He couldn't be careless about anything. The construction of the Jewel of Truth, on the other hand, was...

It’s light work compared to the dam.

All he needed to do was stack together the perfectly sized rocks he had prepared in advance. The job would have been difficult before now as there were so many large rocks to move. But the situation had changed.

“Draggy. Bibeong. Let’s stack them up!”

Clack!

“Bibeong!”

There were two different machines on site whose bodies extended over 300 feet long. That was bigger than the Jewel of Truth, which was 216 feet in length and 98 feet in height. To Draggy and Bibeong, this job was similar to a game of Zenga or Rego blocks.

But they need to work with a lot of precision. There can’t be any mistakes made on where the blocks are placed and how they are fastened into place.

That was the thing with the Jewel of Truth. Everything had to be precisely pieced together. There wasn’t room for even half an inch of error.

This isn’t an ordinary building. The structure itself is a huge magic circle.

Not a single block of perfectly carved stone could be misplaced. He couldn’t allow any leeway on this job.

If I did, any slight errors would cause a subtle change in the building’s flow of mana and make it malfunction eventually.

Lloyd had the impression that the Jewel of Truth was closer to being a giant electric circuit than a magic circle. Anyhow, his eyes became bloodshot as he oversaw the final phase of the dam construction, checked for any errors in the blocks making up the jewel, and scanned countless pieces of engraved rocks with a magnifying glass for any damage or misplacement.

And at last, after about 15 days, just when he started seeing spots in front of his eyes, both the dam and the Jewel of Truth were completed. Lloyd proceeded to fill the dam with water right away. *Woooosh!*

As the water started to fill to its brim, Lloyd intensely gazed at the Jewel of Truth and the dam after activating his surveying skill.

Great. It’s holding up well. Perfect.

The dam handled the large volume of water with ease and also withstood the water pressure around it. The Jewel of Truth, too, stood upright in the water, exactly as Lloyd had planned for it to. Finally, a string of messages began to appear in front of his eyes.

Ding Dong!

[The first concrete dam in Lorasia, the “Frontera Dam”, has been built inside the Frontera Fiefdom.]

[You have showcased a new and unprecedented way to build a dam, and it will be remembered as an important achievement in Lorasia’s history of civil engineering.]

[In the future, engineers will study, analyze, and replicate the Frontera Dam to build more dams across the continent.]

[You will always be regarded as the most experimental and innovative civil engineer in history.]

[Countless civil engineering students will snap their pens in half while cursing your name in anger during their examination periods.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 1,500 RP.]

[Current RP: 1,571]

Whew...

It was just as he had predicted. As soon as the finished dam started to fulfill its purpose, a series of messages about his achievement appeared. Lloyd, however, was still dissatisfied. After all, he had also constructed the Jewel of Truth.

What about my reward for constructing the Jewel of Truth?

He slid his eyes to the side as he had that thought. Soon, his eyes were filled with more welcoming messages.

Ding Dong!

[You have constructed “Aotearoa” or the Jewel of Truth from the mythical ages.]

[It is a structure that possesses immense power and a great cultural legacy that had been lost for all living creatures in this world.]

[You have accomplished a great feat by restoring a great artifact of history.]

[At the same time, your accomplishment caused a variety of different reactions from countless creatures of this world.]

[The Frontera fiefdom residents feel prideful about your accomplishment.]

[The merpeople have become interested in traveling to the Frontera Fiefdom.]

[The angels of the heavens are casting a gaze of concern on Earth.]

[A handful of powerful figures will greed and thirst over the jewel after being enlightened of its existence. This may become a seed of conflict in the future.]

[The demons of Hell, sensing a conflict arising, have brought out their bags of popcorn.]

[For your achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 8,500 RP.]

[Current RP: 10,071]

Eek.

Lloyd clapped his hand over his mouth.

I have 10,000 RP in total.

RP was always the right answer. The more, the better. And this much? Perfect.

I used to jump in joy over earning a few hundred RP.

There were many things he could do with just that much RP. And now, it felt like he was swimming in RP. Despite this, Lloyd remained calm.

This is nothing more than just a simple reward. There's something more important I need to keep in mind.

The RP was comparable to a paycheck. It was something he received as a form of compensation for building the dam and the Jewel of Truth. He then reminded himself of a task he needed to complete. One that had been on his mind since hearing about the Jewel of Truth from the Dragon King. And so, Lloyd dove into the dam to accomplish his goal.

Splash! The water around his body felt cold. When he opened his eyes, he caught sight of a few swaying rays of sunlight, and he swam down toward the Jewel of Truth until he reached its peak. Lloyd then stood in front of the altar made from the Kiaora he found as the final key material for the jewel's construction.

This is how I'm supposed to activate it, right?

Lloyd recalled the operation method attached to the blueprint and placed his hands on the altar. Then, he activated his manaheart and manacircle.

Ziiing! The mana was soon absorbed into the altar from his hand, arousing the Jewel of Truth. The structure began to vibrate, and a shaft of light fell from the sky to illuminate the building. At last, the jewel revealed its truth. Lloyd flinched in response to the booming voice in his ears, as well as the bright droplets of water and streaks of light dancing across his vision.

[You who wish to acquire the answer from the Jewel of Truth... In exchange for an answer, you must reveal one hidden truth about yourself that no one knows about to the world.]

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Chapter 327: You or Me (2)

Everyone has a secret that they don’t want to reveal. This was even more true for someone who was hiding their true identity.

[In exchange for an answer, you must reveal one hidden truth about yourself that no one knows about to the world.]

A voice rang in his ears while droplets of water dizzyingly assembled themselves into words in front of Lloyd. It was a message from the Jewel of Truth, which demanded that Lloyd pay for its services. He scrunched his nose.

What is this? Reveal a hidden truth? A secret about me that only I know? That’s what I need to provide to activate the Jewel of Truth?

Lloyd’s question was answered immediately as if the Jewel of Truth read his mind.

[That is correct, the one who seeks the truth.]

He had doubted his ears, but they were right. To confirm, Lloyd asked once again in desperation.

Wait, does that mean I have to reveal the secret about my identity? Like how I’m actually not Lloyd Frontera or something.

[That does not satisfy the requirement to activate the Jewel of Truth.]

What? Why is that?

[Someone knows that secret aside from you.]

Lloyd concluded that it must be the King of Hell or Dragon King Verkis. Lloyd gave a sigh of relief.

Well, that’s for the better. It’d have been more problematic if I had to reveal that secret.

On second thought, it really was the case.

No one in the fiefdom knows that I'm not the real Lloyd yet. Javier, the count, and the countess don't know. Even the residents of the land are unaware. They merely like and respect me for advancing the fiefdom and all my accomplishments because they think I'm their Lord's son who's next in line to inherit the family name.

What if the fiefdom discovered he wasn't the son of Count and Countess Frontera? Would the people's favor and respect for him remain? Lloyd trembled. He wasn't optimistic about it, and in the worst-case scenario, he would lose all his honor and be exiled.

But still, I have to tell the count and countess one day.

Lloyd had made a promise to the real Lloyd back in Hell that he would come clean to them about what happened to their real son. The thought of breaking their promise never even crossed his mind. It was also what he was compelled to do out of respect for the count and countess. However, now wasn't the right time yet.

Once I finish all my work first, that's when I'll tell the truth, but only to them.

After making that resolution, Lloyd's mind moved on to the issue in front of him.

What am I supposed to reveal to the Jewel of Truth, then? The King of Hell and the Dragon King know about my identity, so that won't work. What could be a hidden truth about me that will be harmless to reveal here?

Lloyd pondered for a long time. At last, something appropriate popped into his head.

Um? How about this? It's a small one.

Lloyd spoke to the Jewel of Truth inwardly.

When I pick my ears, I cotton-swab the bottom first before going clockwise. I move then to the left, top, and right to excavate that gunk. Afterward, I rotate the swab exactly five times on each side to make sure everything's out. This has been my ear-picking routine since I was a child. Does this count?

He tried just in case. That would make this situation a lot easier for him if it did. At last, the Jewel of Truth replied.

[You have shared a truthful secret about yourself that no one else knows about in exchange for a truth you desire to know.]

Oh, oh! It worked!

Lloyd clenched his fists. A split second later, words written in light appeared on the altar's flat surface. They spelled out the secret he had revealed earlier. *Bzzt!*

Similar to a white inscription on a black background, the pale, shiny words began to float until they catapulted out of the water and fixed themselves in the sky for everyone to see. The glittering words were printed across the sky in the same vivid and clear quality as a modern computer screen with QHD resolution.

[Jewel of Truth's Announcement: Lloyd Frontera has a unique way of cleaning his ears. First, he cotton-swabs the bottom... Clockwise... For a successful excavation, five rounds each way... What a wonderful routine of his! This is the truth coming from the Jewel of Truth that tells nothing but the truth.]

When Lloyd looked up at the sky, a wave of shame washed over him. For a long time, he stood in a daze, unable to speak.

Dammit. I should have thought a little harder.

But it was too late. He had to pull himself together.

Okay. Embarrassment is a fleeting emotion. I should be happy I met the requirement without compromising my identity. Now, I can hear the answer I've been looking for.

Yes. It was all good. Embarrassment was a fleeting emotion. There were greater things to come. Thinking so, Lloyd was about to proceed when...

Splash! Abruptly, someone dove into the water and came by his side.

Javier?

Lloyd spotted Javier swimming toward him. His face looked a bit stern for some reason.

"Hey. What brings you all the way down here? I thought I told you to stay far away for safety reasons." Lloyd talked using his underwater breathing skills.

Javier, who couldn't speak, simply gave a nod and made a hand gesture.

"Are you saying that you're fine?" asked Lloyd.

Javier nodded again.

"Hmm, are you here because you wanted to check out what the words in the sky were?"

Another nod.

"I see," continued Lloyd. "You came here because you were worried that something dangerous might happen once the Jewel of Truth is activated."

Javier nodded again.

"So, in short, you were worried about me," said Lloyd, touched.

This time, Javier only gave a hard stare, and his eyes seemed to say, "You're pathetic." He then gave a sigh and shook his head.

“Wow. Are you saying I’m not worth worrying over?” Lloyd guessed aloud from Javier’s gesture.

Javier nodded.

“Why are you here then if you aren’t worried about me?”

Javier didn’t speak. He looked away.

“Seriously,” tutted Lloyd. “You just can’t ever be honest with yourself. So, are the engineers and everyone else somewhere safe now?”

As Javier continued to nod with a straight face, Lloyd couldn’t help but laugh.

This bastard, really.

Lloyd was grateful. Even though Javier was never afraid to lay into him whenever the opportunity arose, he was always there for him in times of need. That was always the case, whether it was when he was trapped in the cave of ants, fighting against Hell's Knight, or battling the Gigatitan. There were more dangerous incidents that followed than he could list, but Javier was always the first to run over and protect him by his side, facing everything with him. With the exception of his muttered complaints, Javier had never seriously expressed his displeasure or left Lloyd alone. The knight was a loyal comrade to the other man.

If I hadn’t intervened in the original plot of the story, Javier would have become a renowned knight across the entire content at this point in time.

But because Lloyd hadn’t died like in the original novel, Javier remained as a knight of his fiefdom, ready to rush toward his side at any time. Lloyd felt both apologetic and grateful for this.

That’s why, you bastard. I’m going to take care of you until the very end. Once I, your wise and older friend, solve the restoration of destiny problem, you’re going to enjoy the rest of your life by my side in peace.

Even though Lloyd wouldn't be able to make him a renowned hero across the continent, he could offer him a lifetime of leisure and indulgence. Thinking so, Lloyd smiled at Javier.

“Fine, you bastard. I’m going to activate the Jewel of Truth now, so stay put and don’t do anything foolish.”

Javier blinked. It was an affirmation. Lloyd then turned around toward the Jewel of Truth and placed his hand on the altar to find the best answer to his question.

I want to find out how I can stop the restoration of destiny.

Lloyd inwardly spoke aloud the question he had been keeping deep inside him. He waited. Soon, the answer came.

Bzzt! His manaheart automatically made a movement, transferring a small amount of mana to the altar. After being amplified, the mana shot up dozens of feet high in the water until it burst through the surface.

A ripple spread across the dam's water, causing a violent shockwave that brought the Jewel’s answer into Lloyd's head.

[Lloyd Frontera is not the main protagonist of this world.]

Eh...?

Lloyd froze at the voice inside his head. He’s not the main protagonist of this world? What could that mean?

Well, that’s just an obvious fact that even I know. Javier is the main protagonist. But my question was how I could stop the restoration of destiny. What’s wrong with this answer?

Something was off, Lloyd could tell. An ominous feeling gripped him. The Jewel continued to answer.

[Lloyd Frontera was originally supposed to die, but he did not. You revived Lloyd Frontera and came to act as the main protagonist, who was originally

supposed to be Javier Asrahan.]

What?

His heart plummeted. A sense of nervousness started to grow in him.

[A person who is not the main protagonist has come to act as one and changed the rule that governs this world. Therefore, this world has perceived you as an error.]

Me? An error?

Lloyd couldn't believe it. Because he took away the main protagonist's role? Because he was acting as one in place of Javier?

[As a result, this world has begun to react in order to return the main protagonist's position to Javier Asrahan and to fulfill Lloyd Frontera's fate by routinely inserting unexpected dangers throughout the story when there is an opportunity to do so. It was all to get rid of you and reintroduce Javier Asrahan as the main protagonist.]

Lloyd was too disoriented to speak. He took a deep breath in and went back to the events that had led up to this point. It finally dawned on him.

So, the ant cave. The warlock. The Gigatitan. The undead Mastodons. Hell's Knight. Draggy... Everything?

They were the world's way of intervening to get rid of him. The thought was outrageous, of course, but it was senseless to deny it. Meanwhile, the Jewel continued its response.

[But you did not die. By surviving each event, you interrupted the intended flow of the story and did not return the role of the main protagonist to Javier Asrahan. Therefore, the world has decided to opt for an alternative plan titled "Incomplete Reset" and remove your existence that is seen as an error.]

The world was forced to resort to a plan called "Incomplete Reset" because he refused to die.

Wait. This incomplete reset... Is it...?

[The “Incomplete Reset” the world has decided to pull is what you are aware of as the restoration of destiny.]

Of course, Lloyd thought.

Dammit.

His fists clenched by themselves. He was taken aback by the revelation about the restoration of destiny.

Ha. So, my existence itself was the problem.

It finally dawned on him. A scoff escaped him as he recalled the plot of *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Lloyd Frontera who died at the beginning of the story. He had desperately tried to lead a respectable life after he found himself in his body. However, all of his choices and actions had disrupted the natural flow of this world. Lloyd, on the other hand, didn't let the revelation hurt him. Instead, he chose to be shameless.

Ha. Why. What? So, what?

Lloyd shot a poisonous glare at the altar. It didn’t matter to him whether the world was trying to kill him or that he had disrupted its natural flow. Up to this point, all he had been doing was diligently working toward building a good life for himself.

So, there’s no need to feel wronged or get discouraged. Everyone tries their best to have a good life, don’t they? Is that a crime? Is that so wrong? What a load of bull.

There was nothing that what he heard now would change even if it was shoved in his face as the truth.

I plan on continuing the life I’ve built for myself until now and allowing myself to leisurely enjoy all it has to offer. The cause behind the restoration of destiny is completely irrelevant. The only thing that matters to me is how I can stop the damned restoration of destiny and the incomplete reset plan.

That was all he cared about. Lloyd didn’t care what the world thought of him or whether they desperately wanted to destroy him. None of it was his problem, and he had no plans to pay any attention to it.

All right, so give me the solution.

Lloyd stared at the altar when he felt a touch on his shoulder. He found Javier staring at him when he turned around.

There was a look of worried concern on Javier’s face. He seemed to be asking if everything was all right.

“Oh, everything’s fine, dude,” assured Lloyd in a bland tone, realizing that his face must have looked pretty grim. He smiled at Javier and thought to himself. *You're my only friend, Javier. I couldn't have overcome all the obstacles in front of me without your help. So, my trustworthy and reliable comrade, stick with me until I become a lazy lord and you become my personal guard. I hope we will be able to grow old together...*

Just then, the Jewel of Truth gave its answer.

[As a result, in order to stop the restoration of destiny, you or Javier Asrahan must die or vanish from this world.]

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Chapter 328: You or Me (3)

[As a result, in order to prevent the restoration of destiny, you or Javier Asrahan must die or vanish from this world.]

What...?

Lloyd froze, doubting his ears. What did he just hear?

Has it lost its mind? What nonsense did I just hear?

He hoped he heard wrong or that there was some kind of a technical glitch. But the response the Jewel of Truth gave next was as cold as the previous one.

[It is an undeniable fact. At the moment, all the errors of this world happened because you were acting as the main protagonist of the story without permission. As such, you have two choices. Die and give Javier Asrahan the position of the main protagonist. Otherwise, kill Javier Asrahan and become the rightful main protagonist.]

Lloyd turned and gave a glance at Javier, who was eyeing him with more concern on his face.

My face must have become paler.

It appeared to be. That would explain the worried expression on Javier’s face, which was uncharacteristic of him. Lloyd tried to quickly put on a smile that he hoped didn’t look too awkward. The Jewel of Truth, on the other hand, continued to speak as if it didn't realize what state Lloyd was in at the moment.

[Once one of you disappears, the world will finally choose the remaining person as the rightful protagonist and perceive there to be no more error to fix. That is only when the incomplete reset plan to carry out the restoration of destiny will come to a halt, and the story will develop around the existing hero.]

By this point, Lloyd was so drained that he didn’t have enough energy to even sigh. Sure, he had grown vaguely concerned over the past months that the restoration of destiny was linked to his possession of Lloyd's body and the resulting change of plot. But it never occurred to him that the solution would necessitate him to make such a cruel decision.

Just tell me that I need to earn more RP to prevent the restoration of destiny. Come on.

Lloyd sincerely wanted that to be the case. He was willing to pay tens of thousands of RP if needed. No, even if it cost a whopping 100,000 RP, that would be about 100,000 times better than the solution he was given.

If that was the answer, I would just need to do more construction projects. Then, I would still have a chance to solve the issue even if it required strenuous effort and backbreaking work from me. But... I don’t know what to do with this.

It was either him or Javier. One of them had to die. Vanish from the face of this world. Otherwise, the infuriating restoration of destiny would not be stopped.

What am I supposed to do now?

I don’t know. I really don’t know. Not a clue. Lloyd thought to himself in despair. He wasn’t sure if he would be able to devise a solution.

Wait a minute... What if I die and use my benefit from Dragon King’s sponsorship? And come back to life? Would it stop the restoration of destiny since I’m technically dead?

The Jewel of Truth gave an answer to Lloyd’s sudden idea.

[That is impossible. Eventually, you will come to exist again in this world, so the restoration of destiny will resume as soon as you are revived.]

Dammit. That seemed like a clever plan for a moment, a faint light amidst the darkness around him. But Lloyd didn’t give up. Grasping at straws, he

tried another question.

Then, how about an alternative solution? Is there any other method that doesn't involve either of us dying? Any way to the slow restoration of destiny?

[There is none.]

Its curt response severed Lloyd's last strand of hope. Even after that, he tossed out a few questions in the hopes that one of them would work, such as making a declaration to give over the protagonist's role to Javier or revealing that he was not the real Lloyd and asking for everyone's forgiveness. Better yet, leaving the fiefdom altogether. Lloyd tested any idea he could think of using the Jewel of Truth. But the answer he received remained the same.

[It is impossible.]

It was beyond him why all of his suggestions were rejected. Maybe it was because he was labeled as an error, and there was no way of changing that. Perhaps the story had deviated too far from the original plot for his proposed plans to work. There was only one thing that was clear for him.

It's me or Javier. Just one of us. That's the only solution.

Suddenly, it felt like his vision clouded over with darkness. Even as the Jewel of Truth created massive waves above him that crashed against the dam and overflowed into the spillway, Lloyd was blind to what was going on around him. He couldn't even care to notice anything.

What am I supposed to do now?

It felt like his heart was being ripped in half. Javier, unaware of his feelings, continued to ask if he was okay with his gaze.

"Yeah, I'm fine. Really," managed Lloyd. He forced himself to smile. But Javier was unconvinced. The knight asked through his gaze if the Jewel of

Truth had not given him an answer, or worse, if it provided a nonsensical response based on the grim look on his face.

“I’ve found the answer. And thankfully, it’s nothing strange. It looks like we can stop the restoration of destiny without much difficulty.”

If one of us dies, that is. Lloyd smiled, thinking to himself.

The more his heart continued to throb, the bleaker his situation seemed to be. Lloyd tried to put on a brighter smile. And later, even on his way up to the surface with Javier, he continued brooding over the matter. But nothing in particular came to his mind.

This is bad. I really don’t see a way out this time.

A sudden desire to bury his face in his hands came over him.

Scams and tricks only work when there’s a loophole I can take advantage of. They work by exploiting a weak point that no one else can see. But this time, there’s no loophole for me to use. The Jewel gave a clear-cut response with no room for interpretation. There is no other way out of this situation without choosing between me or Javier.

One of the two had to die or vanish from this world. There was no other answer. No matter how hard Lloyd agonized and thought over the issue, he couldn’t find a clever solution.

What if one of us went to another dimension?

Asking Dragon King Verkis to send him to another dimension seemed doable.

Like the last time I went to Seoul.

He could go or send Javier. The person who left would never come back. That would stop the restoration of destiny without a doubt.

I don’t like that thought, though. No, I hate the idea.

Lloyd shook his head forcefully.

It wouldn't be right for me to send Javier away. Even if I don't have a conscience, I know that would be going too far. But on the other hand, making myself return to Seoul sounds even worse.

The mere thought of returning to Seoul and staying there forever made his nose scrunch up.

I hate that city.

Lloyd honestly despised the place. He knew no one and was practically an orphan there. Plus, the city was filled with bad memories rather than good ones for him.

That's why I busted my gut in this world. I saw my chance to live a more meaningful, happier life here. Whereas in Seoul, I was going to die after living a life of emptiness.

That was why Lloyd was able to accomplish so much here. And thanks to it, the fruits of his labor were beginning to emerge recently. For the first time in his life, he was treated with dignity, respect, and admiration.

Yet, I need to throw all that away and go back to Seoul? Not a chance.

The more he toyed with the idea in his head, the sicker he felt.

Plus, if I get there, I'll be Lloyd Frontera. Not Suho Kim. I'll have no family, home, property, bank account, passport, or even a transportation card. I'll be a poor, undocumented immigrant as soon as I get there.

Death seemed to be a better choice than going back. Lloyd naturally drew a conclusion from that.

I'm scrapping any plans of going back to Seoul.

He would look for other methods instead. There had to be a way out that he wasn't seeing. A brilliant, clever scheme was certainly waiting to be unearthed by him.

I still have some time. There are still two years left until the restoration of destiny begins. And if I need more time, I'll just freeze the flow of time and try to think of something.

There was no need to rush into disappointment just yet, let his heart drown in despair, or give up hope. With that resolve, Lloyd rose toward the surface with his legs. He wrapped up his thoughts, calculations, and final decisions in a span of a few seconds as he swam up. A cheering crowd greeted him as soon as his head popped above the water.

"Huraaaaay!"

"Eh...?" He blinked hard as exclaiming voices boomed across the land. As he removed a cluster of hair stuck to his face, Lloyd looked around to find a cheering crowd.

"The water flowed just as you had designed! It is a success, Master Lloyd!"

"Sir Bayern...?" Sir Bayern came into Lloyd's view. He was standing on the edge of the lake that was created from the dam. Lloyd also noticed the engineers with shovels in their hands. They were not, however, the only ones he saw. There were members of the White Cavalry shouting and scribbling something on their hands on the other side of the dam. Lloyd's senses as a swordmaster allowed him to pick up on some of their words.

"Hey, do you have any coal left?" Vice Commander Orlando asked the guy beside him.

"Ah, hold on, Sir Orlando," muttered the guy. "I'm writing something on my palm right now."

"I'll forget what I was planning to write at this rate."

"I can write for both of us," replied the soldier casually, still focusing on his writing.

"Then make sure you don't make a mistake. As far as I can remember, Master Lloyd cleans his ear from the bottom."

“Yes, I remember, too. Then, he goes clockwise. It was five rounds in each direction. Right?”

“You are right,” Orlando affirmed. “It did say that. Make sure to write that down. That’s the ear-cleaning method of a sword master. It may seem like nothing but could hold an important meaning that we haven’t realized yet.”

“Of course,” observed the guy, still jotting down, “After all, this is a routine habit of a man who is a swordmaster.”

“Indeed. We must follow his ways and learn from them at every chance. This is the best and most updated form of education we can get.”

“You are right, sir. We must overcome our own swordmaster syndrome soon too.”

“That is what I’m talking about!”

These kinds of unbelievable conversations were taking place amongst the White Cavalry.

Stop it, you nut-jobs. I can understand your desperation because I’ve suffered from it too... But this is just too much.

Lloyd felt a shaft of fright run over his body. But he had no choice but to deal with it because even after those burdensome praises, exclamations, and compliments, a slew of new cheers appeared. When Lloyd met the orc warriors, their faces turned scarlet as they shouted, “I knew Lloyd could do it! Lloyd is our friend, oink!” “Lloyd is awesome!” “He made a large dam, oink!” “Lloyd is cool! He even constructed the Jewel of Truth, oink!” “But he can’t find a girlfriend, oink!”

Their passionate, over-the-top reaction was infectious. Even Moira, the elf chief, was affected by it.

“Lloyd Frontera, you are truly amazing,” remarked Moira when she bumped into Lloyd one day.

“Excuse me...? What are you talking about?” replied Lloyd, baffled.

“I have seen it with my own eyes.”

“Seen what...?”

“The Jewel of Truth’s activation,” she explained softly. “The wave in the artificial lake spilled into the spillway extremely smoothly. Your actions saved a host of plants as a result.”

“Oh, do you mean the bushes growing around the lake?” Lloyd did remember them.

“Yes,” she affirmed as she put her hand over to her chest. “I was touched just like the time you moved all the plants around the construction site of the dam that would be hit with its waves.”

“Oh.” Lloyd put on an embarrassed smile. “That’s because those plants were valuable medicinal-”

“I am sure,” Moira broke in, “You built the dam considering even something like this in mind. What a kind man you are.”

Saving a bunch of medicinal plants happened by chance. It was an unintended outcome of his actions. As a result, he could only give an embarrassed smile in response to the compliments he received. Moreover, to be honest, Lloyd didn’t have time to acknowledge every compliment he was given. He was smiling on the outside, but there was a storm inside him.

It’s me or Javier.

The tyrannical path of destiny would only stop if one of them died. What kind of disgusting joke was this? Every time he thought about it, his head ached. It never occurred to him that the Jewel of Truth he had worked so hard to construct would present him with such an awful solution to prevent the restoration of destiny.

Oh, crap.

Would he be able to find the solution if he continued to ponder like this? What if he was wasting his time here? Even as he reassured himself that

everything would be fine, Lloyd had to fight and suppress the ball of nervousness that was growing inside him.

And yet... people are praising me, totally ignorant of everything.

Lloyd suddenly felt a surge of loneliness. He wanted to share his worries with someone, but no one knew he even had any concerns. This made him feel like a lost child, separated from everyone. After five days of forcing himself to laugh over meaningless compliments and put on a bright smile, someone at the dinner table extended a helping hand to him.

“You have had a gloomy expression on your face recently. Is something troubling you?” Countess Marbella carefully asked him a question as if she was gently patting him on the back.

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Chapter 329: A New Grand Plan (1)

“Is something troubling you?” The question was set in an ever so careful and comforting tone, like a gentle pat on his back.

“I'm sorry?” Lloyd was startled out of his reverie when he noticed Countess Marbella looking at him across the dinner table. That's when he realized he'd been fiddling with his salad without eating. “Oh, I've got something on my mind,” he said hurriedly, forcing his lips to move upward and putting on the same bright smile he'd been showing often as of late. Count Marbella, on the other hand, was not convinced.

“If you are tired, you can say so, my dear. It is all right.” She smiled as well. It was faint, but there was warmth unlike his. “Your father and I know how hard you’ve continued to work. How can we not after seeing all your accomplishments?”

“That’s...” Lloyd couldn’t finish his sentence.

“Did you not get the answer you wanted from the Jewel of Truth that was built recently?”

Lloyd clamped his lips shut. Mothers. They saw through everything.

I thought I was hiding it perfectly.

Lloyd hadn't stopped smiling in the past few days. When people showered him with compliments and praise, he proudly shrugged in an effort to act like he was enjoying every moment of it. But it turned out that he was mistaken. What Count Marbella said next confirmed his realization.

“Sir Asrahan has told us that you have been acting strange lately,” she remarked while locking her fingers together on the table.

“He did?” Lloyd raised his brows.

“Yes. He says that it looks like you are avoiding him.”

“Well, that’s because I’m a busy man. Hahaha!”

Count Marbella’s eyes ran over Lloyd in suspicion at his sudden outburst of laughter.

“He didn’t whine about how upset he is, did he?” Lloyd asked nonchalantly.

“He was very worried about you. And Sir Asrahan is not the only one that is.”

“What? Then, who else-”

“Sir Bayern submitted a report yesterday to Arcos. It said that you have been acting unusually upbeat these days.”

Lloyd cleared his throat.

“He is worried too,” added Count Marbella. “Because to him, it looks like you are acting that way on purpose. He wrote your face is smiling, but there is a gloominess to it on a closer look.”

Lloyd was utterly dazed. He couldn’t speak at all. It turned out that his behavior had been transparent all along.

“There are others,” she continued softly. “Sir Blanc, Arosh, Moira, and Turtle Neck. Everyone is worried. They all say that you seem to be brooding over something after using the Jewel of Truth.”

“...”

“Your father and I have made a similar observation.” Countess Marbella spoke, her voice dripping with concern. “You have been unusually quiet recently and often forcing yourself to smile, only to be lost in your thoughts once again. Did you think we would not notice?”

“Um, no...” Lloyd honestly didn’t think they’d notice. He thought he had been putting on a good act. As he scratched his head in embarrassment, his face turned crimson red.

Wow. I guess I was too obvious, and my feelings were written all over my face. My act must have been terrible.

Lloyd couldn't believe that everyone had been whispering their concerns behind his back while he walked around like a fool with a bright smile on his face. Lloyd grumbled, his face flushing with embarrassment.

Dang. If I was that obvious, someone might as well have told me I was. No one here has good manners.

In one part, however, Lloyd understood why they weren't able to say anything to him. They were worried that bringing up the subject might stress him more. They must have simply watched him from afar for his sake.

My goodness. Haah. These people are too kind.

Lloyd exhaled like a deflating balloon, the corners of his lips rising. He wanted to keep the matter to himself and solve the issue on his own. It wasn't something that could be discussed openly. His plan was to struggle alone to find a solution. He never imagined anyone would notice his behavior in the process. Even if he was exposed, however, he had no intention of sharing his concerns with them.

I'll just thank them for their kind intentions.

His dilemma couldn't be revealed in any case. How could he reveal to the others that either he or Javier had to die?

No one knows what Javier will do once he finds out.

Javier would immediately throw his life away if he found out that one of them had to vanish for the safety of the Frontera family. That was the kind of person Javier Asrahan was.

He'd do it even if he hates me. His loyalty toward Count Frontera is absolute.

Lloyd was well aware that Javier was always prepared to make any sacrifice necessary for Count Frontera and his family.

So, I can never tell him about the Jewel of Truth's answer to my question.

There was another problem with explaining his dilemma. It was that he'd have to reveal his identity and explain how he'd taken Javier's role as the main protagonist. Lloyd wasn't going to do that. The time was not yet right.

"Um, I am sorry." Lloyd craned his head a little lower and spoke in a grave tone. "To be honest, something is indeed worrying me. But I can't share my concerns with you at the moment."

"Is there a reason for that, my dear?"

"Yes." Lloyd nodded as he looked down.

She gave a concerned look. "Is it related to the restoration of destiny that you told us about the last time?"

Lloyd looked her in the eyes. "I can't tell you in detail, but yes. That's largely it. But I assure you..." He paused for a moment. "I will tell you everything when this whole thing is over." That was it. When the time came, he'd tell them about all the worries that had plagued his mind and the truth about his identity. Everything would be revealed. Lloyd hoped that the day would arrive as soon as possible.

Countess Marbella gave a gentle smile, and her voice sounded more assuring than a second ago. "I see. Until then, I will continue to cheer you on."

"Thank you." Lloyd felt grateful that she didn't press further.

"But promise me one thing."

"Yes?"

"Whenever you are going through a hard time, please tell us honestly," urged Countess Marbella. "Even if you try to hide it, everyone will be able

to see through you.”

“Ehem...” Lloyd cleared his throat. “I will.”

“And one more thing.”

“What is it?”

“You may think I am being nosy here... If something is worrying you, try to focus on something else for a bit.”

“Come again?” The suggestion took Lloyd by surprise. “Focus on something else...?”

“A simple problem you can solve right at the moment.”

“A simple problem...”

“Yes,” she suggested. “A simple problem. A trivial and easy problems that you can solve without much time or effort. At times, focusing on such problems can lead to answers for a bigger dilemma.”

“Oh.” Lloyd felt his world become brighter as soon as he processed the advice in his head as if a ray of light shone ahead of him. His world had been dim and dark since the Jewel of Truth's response, but for the first time, his heart felt liberated.

That could be it.

Of course, it wasn’t that he found the solution. But he did manage to have a realization from her suggestion.

I was too caught up thinking about a problem that couldn’t be answered right away. My perspective has narrowed. This won’t do. The more I obsess over one problem, the harder it will be to come up with a dynamic solution.

Looking back, Lloyd realized that this particular dilemma had taken over his mind for the past few days. He would never be able to find a new approach or solution in this state.

Okay. She's right. I have to shift my focus. Let's try to work on another problem. Hmm... How about the side effect of the Heart of Winter?

That, too, wasn't a simple issue. But it was relatively easier to deal with than the dilemma of choosing whether Javier or he should die.

That's right. One thing at a time. I need to prioritize urgent matters first. Ice Dragon Tyrannus said that ignoring the negative side effect of absorbing the Heart of Winter will cause it to spread across my entire body like cancer and drastically shorten my lifespan.

In some ways, this could be seen as a more urgent issue. It could be what calls for his attention before anything else.

So, for the time being, I'll take care of the side effects from absorbing the Heart of Winter first. At the same time, I'll continue to think about how I should deal with the information I learned from the Jewel of Truth.

In any case, he had nearly two years until the restoration of destiny would begin. Lloyd became suddenly convinced that he could solve the problem while dealing with other issues in front of him.

"Ha..." Finally, he felt a weight lift off his shoulders. He regained his lost appetite for the first time in several days. "I will do that. I really appreciate it." Lloyd bowed again to Countess Marbella as he picked up his fork. Even a moment ago, he couldn't get himself to care for any of the food placed in front of him. But he was suddenly hit with an intense pang of hunger.

It's been a while since I had an appetite.

And then he began digging in his meal. Lloyd was disappointed that he couldn't have kimchi jjigae with mackerel and white rice instead of salad and sausage. However, he still enjoyed the dishes on his dinner table. Countess Marbella looked at Lloyd with a satisfied expression on her face. And she thought to herself...

Lloyd... used to loathe cleaning his ears.

Lloyd had a particular aversion to it since he was a child. Every time she tried to clean his ears, he acted as if he was having a panic attack, threw tantrums, and floundered around. Thus, he made it impossible for her to use the cotton swabs on him. Eventually, she gave up on trying.

He's been like that since he was a baby. When he got older, he grumbled about how much he hated the feeling of a cotton swab entering his ear. He said it was disgusting, even. He believed it was harmless to not clean his ears.

That was Lloyd. The child who vowed to never clean his ears. Countess Marbella knew every single detail about her son. As such, a part of her was saddened.

The Jewel of Truth, on the other hand...

It wrote an announcement in the sky about Lloyd's special way of cleaning his ears. She couldn't believe what she saw. There was only one of the two possibilities, she had concluded to herself. The Jewel of Truth, that mythical building, had lied.

If not...

Count Marbella stared across from the table. Lloyd was busily enjoying his meal. A shaft of grief filled her eyes.

***

Ha. This is sad, very sad. Why do I have to do this now?

Lloyd grumbled as he walked to his room after a satisfying dinner. But his face was more relaxed than before, and at times, a random chuckle escaped him. It was because he had an epiphany at the dinner table while listening to Countess Marbella's advice.

I feel calm for the first time in a while. Now, I can focus on a problem I can solve right now.

Lloyd had mulled over a solution to treat the side effects he suffered from absorbing the Heart of Winter during dinner.

The solution is actually simple. Tyrannus told me what it is. I just need to attain a divine item that possesses the opposite nature of the Heart of Winter.

The Tears of Summer. It was another divine item of the House of Magentano.

I just have to get it in my hands. The problem is how.

Lloyd had racked his brain for the entirety of dinner. The things he could do. The things he couldn't do. Any loopholes he could capitalize on. And countless possibilities and outcomes that could follow. Lloyd pondered, speculated, and weighed over the situation.

As he took the last bite of his salad, a brilliant epiphany struck him, lifting so much weight off his shoulders that he practically floated back to his room. He then summoned his maid, Emily, and assigned her an errand. She returned from it by the time he finished cleaning up his room. On the tray she was holding was a bowl of cold water.

"Um, young master, I brought the cold water you asked for," announced Emily with uncertainty in her voice.

"Okay. Thank you. Just put it over there," instructed Lloyd casually.

"Are you not going to drink it?"

"Nope. Leave it there and be gone now. Thank you. Good night."

Lloyd practically shoved Emily out of his room and shut the door. He looked at the bowl on the desk after smoothing his clothes. He knelt, clasped his hands against his chest, and began to beg the heavens.

"I pray, I pray. Lloyd Frontera of the beneath world prays to the upper realm's holy angels. Please transport me to the heavens. Please summon me. I am a sinner. I defied the demolition order by attacking and harassing an

angel. I'm sorry for what I've done. So, I implore you! Please! Take! Me! Right away!"

His prayer had an ulterior motive. Lloyd begged and begged toward the cold bowl of water to be summoned immediately, recalling Raphael's prayer of complaint. Was he acting this way because he had suddenly gone mad? Absolutely not.

This is how I will attain the Tears of Summer!

Lloyd frantically prayed, recalling his grand plan. Could it be that his prayer worked? The heavens intervened about an hour into his fervent hand-rubbing and murmuring, just as he was beginning to question its efficacy.

Fwoosh! Abruptly, his bedroom was enveloped with brilliant rays of light, which was followed by an emergence of angels one after another.

It worked!

A total of six Thrones and Dominion angels. Lloyd gave them a welcoming smile as they arrived.

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Chapter 330: A New Grand Plan (2)

“Wow! This must be what Heaven is like.” Lloyd's gaze swept the breathtaking surroundings. Everything he saw was spotlessly white. The sleek floor. The temple pillars, the sky, and the holy sun in the sky. Everything was white and radiated pure holiness.

“Woah,” observed Lloyd. “Doesn’t it feel like we’re a germ or cockroach that intruded inside somewhere we shouldn’t be.”

“You know, Young Master, you can keep those kinds of thoughts to yourself...”

“Nope,” defied Lloyd. “Can’t do that.”

Irritated, Javier tightly pressed his lips together, and a notion occurred to him while he gazed at the divine sight around him. How did he end up here after being pulled out by Lloyd from his comfortable position in bed?

Ha... It’s my fault for getting involved with this man in the first place.

Why, of all people, did this type of man have to possess Lloyd Frontera's body. Why did he have to take him to such unexpected places at every chance he had? Javier resentfully reflected on the past. However, there was only one conclusion he could draw.

It’s just because he’s a bad person.

His mind went back to the events that had occurred prior to his arrival. He was lying on his bed about an hour ago, having finished the cleanup for the dam’s construction site and completed all his exhausting chores for the day while also worrying about Lloyd’s evasive behavior recently. He was tossing and turning in his bed, trying to sleep, when the door burst open with a voice saying, “Hey! Let’s go to Heaven!”

I thought he had lost it at first.

Who barged into someone’s room and demanded they travel to Heaven? Javier tried to calm Lloyd down and help him get a grip on himself, believing that he had finally gone mad. Javier even considered knocking him out for a few seconds as a form of medical treatment. Lloyd's next move, however, surpassed his imagination.

“Come on! Let’s go!” Lloyd held out his hand to grab Javier’s and yanked it up, leaving no time for the knight to respond.

Finally making sense of the situation, Javier managed, “Where on earth are you suggesting we go?”

“I told you!” bawled Lloyd excitedly. “To Heaven!”

Okay. That was it for Javier. He was about to knock Lloyd out when he saw six angels standing in a line in the corridor.

"All right, Young Master," Javier said as he finished recalling the previous events. "I can accept the fact that I was forced to come to Heaven with you. However, I have a question." Javier swiveled his head toward Lloyd. His eyes were filled with suspicion. "What on earth am I doing here?"

“Hmm?” retorted Lloyd innocently. “You?”

“Yes.” The suspicion in his eyes grew. “You told me a while ago in the corridor as you introduced me to the angels that Raphael was right about the heavens sending them to take you away and that I was to tag along.”

“Yes, I did,” Lloyd said matter-of-factly.

“That is what I’m curious about.”

“About what?” inquired Lloyd patiently.

Javier frowned. “The angels descended down to take you away.”

“That’s right.”

“So, what am I doing here with you?”

Lloyd looked Javier in the eyes as if the question couldn't be more absurd. "I'm scared to go alone."

That completely silenced Javier, who had been almost persuaded for a split second by Lloyd's outrageous gibberish due to his shameless attitude. "You are scared?" Javier blurted out, quickly gathering himself and screwing up his nose. "Is that why you brought me here? That is a bad joke."

"I'm serious. It's not a joke," replied Lloyd with a straight face.

"..."

"Come on," went on Lloyd. "This isn't a neighborhood or kingdom next to us. It's Heaven. Quite literally Heaven. Although different from Hell, this is also a place for the dead. Plus, should I also remind you that I was coerced into coming here? I didn't come here for a fun vacation. It only makes sense for me to be scared of coming here alone."

"Well, that is..." Javier's voice faltered.

"So, you have to protect me by my side."

Javier narrowed his eyes.

"That's how much I trust you, my knight."

Lloyd Frontera. Javier was astonished by the man's ability to occasionally move him with his sincerity like now. But Javier pretended he wasn't moved and tutted, "You trust me, Young Master? Please don't say something so ridiculous."

"But I'm seriously serious," pressed Lloyd.

"I say that you are rather bored."

"Oops," giggled Lloyd. "You got me."

Javier didn't respond.

Lloyd clapped his hands. “Let’s move faster, shall we? Why are you so slow? Are you a turtle?”

Suddenly, Javier felt a shaft of irritation.

“You know, you might as well answer if you’re asked a question. Let’s go, Javier the Turtle.”

“Master Lloyd,” huffed Javier gravely. “I am neither a turtle nor Javier the __”

“All right. I get it. Sir Javier Asrahan. No need to get upset over what I said. Tsk.”

Lloyd chuckled. Truly, Javier was a fun guy to tease. However, an unpleasant message appeared whenever Lloyd went too far with his teasing. Like now.

[Javier Asrahan thought that your joke crossed the line.]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has decreased by one point.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: +67]

[Even though your relationship with a major character has slightly worsened, your RP remains unchanged and will not be forfeited.]

[Current RP: 10,071]

Ha. I guess I went out too far.

Lloyd gave a wry smile. Javier’s reaction was actually understandable, given that he was dragged out of his bed to this celestial place. But as far as Lloyd was concerned, he didn’t have any other choice.

Of course. Who knows what will happen here? I really was nervous about coming alone.

It was nowhere other than Heaven. Moreover, he wasn’t here for a good reason.

I mean, even though I stand to gain a lot from this visit if it all goes according to my plan, you can never be certain that everything will go as expected. That's why I need someone to look out for me if things go wrong.

Thinking that taking Javier was only a natural decision for him, Lloyd moved on as he stole glances at the faces of the angels escorting him. They were the same angels who had come down to pick him up.

Two Thrones angels. The rest... The Dominion angels?

The Thrones angels held the same amount of power as grandmasters. Dominion angels were slightly less powerful than that. Aside from them, the angels flying about the area also exuded a menacing energy.

Most of them are those in the lower ranks of the Principalities to Angels. Comparing them to humans, they’d be somewhere between a high-level sword expert and a swordmaster. The Virtues I intermittently see are equivalent to swordmasters. This place is filled with powerful angels.

His shoulders drooped naturally, and he was glad he had brought Javier with him. It meant he could buy some time to stall and flee with him if a fight erupted, which Lloyd knew would be impossible to win.

They soon came to a large door that was about 120 feet tall and 60 feet wide and hung in the air. There was no wall or frame around it. There was merely a large white door hanging in the air. Lloyd even peered around the corner, but nothing was there.

One of the angels gestured to the door and said, “Please open the door and go in.”

“Open this one?” asked Lloyd, gulping.

“Yes, but your guard should stay here. Please go in alone. The minister should be inside.”

Lloyd figured that the angel was referring to Gabriel the Seraph. Clasping the handle, he pushed the door open. Just then... *Fwoosh!*

Eh?

His entire surroundings changed after a brief moment of nausea as if someone had used transportation magic on him.

Where am I?

Lloyd's gaze darted around the room, trying to calm his nauseated stomach. The entire setting had been converted into a large office. The walls and floor, as well as the bookshelf and books, were all white. The desk and chair were white as well as if the entire place had been designed by someone who was obsessed with the color white. Lloyd then noticed an immaculate angel sitting straight in his chair, gently smiling.

“Welcome. Have a seat.”

Lloyd wordlessly obeyed. After taking a seat across from the angel, he leaned forward and said, “Nice to meet you. I am Lloyd Frontera, the human from the mundane realm.”

Lloyd figured the angel must be Gabriel. Determined to make a good first impression on him, he gulped and observed the angel’s reaction.

The angel beamed. “I am aware. I have been watching over your every move. It is a pleasure to meet you. I am Gabriel, the Minister of Angels.”

“Nice to meet you,” Lloyd said as he put on a modest and humble smile. “I am infinitely honored to be in the presence of the Minister of Angels who possesses such great reputation, honor, glory, joy, and praise.”

Gabriel raised his brow at the groveling remark. “Really...?”

“Yes, minister.”

“I think you are lying,” accused Gabriel, unaffected.

“I would never lie to you.”

“I suggest you wipe the sweat off yourself before you speak.”

“Please forgive me...” Lloyd trailed off, inwardly scrapping his plan to win him over with flattery. He suppressed a bitter smile.

Gabriel put on a similar expression. “Anyway, thank you for agreeing to come here without a fight. Unlike what happened last time.”

“By that, you mean...”

“Raphael the Throne. You put up quite a fierce resistance against him while he tried to carry out his duty.”

Lloyd avoided Gabriel’s gaze.

“I am sure you are aware why I called for you here today.

“Yes, I am.”

“Then, care to tell me the reason yourself?”

“Haah...” sighed Lloyd. “I didn’t abide by the demolition order of the Jewel of Truth and interfered with Raphael’s efforts to carry out his duties as a public official of Heaven. I suppose you wanted to interrogate me about it all.”

“You are smart. I like that. You are exactly right.”

“Thank you, minister.”

“Thank you? You should be offering at least one hundred apologies instead,” said Gabriel in a reproachful tone.

Ever so carefully, Lloyd spoke in a humble tone. “On what ground should I apologize...”

“Do you not know?” Gabriel was slightly taken aback by Lloyd’s question.

Lloyd closed his mouth. Gabriel's benevolent eyes began to become stern and stringent. "What do you think of the heavens' decision, Human Lloyd Frontera? Do you see it as a tyrannical move from selfish higher-ups who are unconcerned about those in the mundane realm?"

Yes, I do, Lloyd thought to himself.

Gabriel's criticism continued. "But, human Lloyd Frontera, you see. You are off in your assessment. The present is not the only factor when we make decisions. We also take into account the numerous possibilities and risks that our decision may have on the universe in its present, past, and future." Gabriel's voice grew commanding. "Now, do you dare tell me that you are arrogant enough to believe you are above Heaven’s wisdom with your menial judgment, hopes, and willpower as a human?"

Lloyd didn’t rush into response. He remained silent, listening to what Gabriel had to say.

“That is truly an arrogant thought. I am aware that such propensity can be easily observed in smart humans, but I thought you were different. How utterly disappointing.”

Even then, Lloyd didn’t speak.

“This should be enough to enlighten you of your wrongdoing. Do speak if you have something to say,” urged Gabriel. His benevolent tone was back.

“Oh, yes, My Grace. But before that,” Lloyd said as he gently smiled, “May I bother you with a question?”

“Do ask now,” allowed Gabriel.

"Yes, thank you." Lloyd licked his lips with saliva as he noticed Gabriel's sternness in his eyes. He was well aware that he needed to tread carefully. As a result, he phrased his question with great care, as if he were testing the water, which he knew was shallow.

“Um, the thing is...” finally managed Lloyd, “Um... If ever I present a rebutting argument to what you have just said...”

“A rebutting argument?” Gabriel echoed.

“Yes,” said Lloyd as he nodded. “This is just to be certain. But if I rebut your words... Will I be hated by you and receive great misfortune in the future?”

Being an angel, the question didn’t make sense to Gabriel. “Hated? Receive great misfortune? What do you mean?”

“Oh, I mean, would you do something along the lines of kill me immediately and send me to Hell?”

"Hell? Haha." Gabriel burst out laughing at the ridiculousness of the thought. "That will never happen. Are you inquiring if you would go to Hell over giving an opposing argument? That would be completely unacceptable. That is something that can never happen."

“I-is that so?” Lloyd felt a whoosh of relief.

“Of course,” replied Gabriel benevolently. “Where you go after you pass depends on the total score of your good and bad deeds. It is impossible for an angel to deduct or add any points from your score. Regardless of an angel’s rank, they are all those who are serving Heaven, not an object of worship.”

“Oh,” observed Lloyd with glee, “Is that the same case for you, my angel?”

“Indeed.” Gabriel flashed a stringent and generous smile. He knew what he was. Angels were workers, tools that execute the will of God into the world. They could not and must not be objects of worship.

“As such, if you have any words of rebuttal, do feel free to speak up,” Gabriel urged kindly. “Whatever you bring up, I shall not hold it against you.”

“Do you really mean that?” Lloyd asked, whose tone grew a little more excited.

“Of course.”

“Mean it with all your heart?” asked Lloyd again. This time, his voice went higher in pitch.

“I do.” Gabriel nodded.

“Promise, my angel?” He gestured with his pinky finger.

“Consider it done.”

“Thank you.”

“Do not be.”

“Of course, I should be grateful,” replied Lloyd. By now, his tone was more relaxed than ever. “Okay, so since you have given me the assurance, why don’t we sit down and have a fruitful discussion on how senseless and ludicrous your teaching is regarding the demolition of the Jewel of Truth.”

“Hmm?” Gabriel stopped for a second. Just then, a thought interrupted him. *Why on earth was this human licking his lips with a smile as if he were talking to a naive fool?*

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Chapter 331: Conditional Agreement (1)

“Hmm...?” Stopping, Gabriel thought to himself...

What is with this sudden change in his attitude?

Until a moment ago, the human was cautiously watching for Gabriel’s reactions, afraid he would say the wrong thing, slight him, and be punished. The man's effort to appease him was obvious, as was his careful and measured demeanor. However, now...

All I did was tell him the truth: every angel, regardless of their rank, is merely someone who works for the heavens. We are not, and should not be, objects of worship. That's what I told him, and now...

There was now a dramatic shift in the man’s attitude. He was no longer looking at the angel’s face, and his careful expression and demeanor had vanished.

Gabriel was completely taken aback by his abrupt change. “What...? You want to sit down and nitpick why my argument is nonsense...?”

“Yes. Please forgive me, but that’s what I would like to do,” Lloyd licked his lips before launching into his rebuttal, which he had prepared and let marinate in his head like a well-aged wine on his entire way to Heaven. “First and foremost, please allow me to ask you a question. Regarding the Jewel of Truth that your realm is taking an issue with, may I know when the building was made illegal?”

“Based on the mundane realm’s standard of time?” asked Gabriel with a frown.

“Yes.”

“That is easy. Exactly 4,640,655 days, twelve hours, twenty minutes, and sixteen seconds ago,” counted Gabriel.

Lloyd looked up, thinking. “Oh, um, then... 12,714 years, one month, and fifteen days ago?”

“Yes, something like that.”

Lloyd gave a nod. “Then, the Jewel must have been determined to be unlawful before I started its construction?”

“Indeed.”

In a thoughtful tone, Lloyd remarked, “But why didn’t I receive any notice or instruction at the time I started the construction?”

“What?” Gabriel was taken aback by Lloyd’s sharp question.

Lloyd’s knife-sharp criticism continued. “I clearly remember. No one notified or warned me in any way that the Jewel of Truth was an illegal structure when I decided to start this project. That certainly seems like an issue, doesn’t it?”

Gabriel frowned, starting to sense where Lloyd was going.

“Think about it,” Lloyd continued. “The Jewel of Truth has been outlawed by the heavens. To build that would be a very serious crime. Thus, whoever breaks the law will get into a lot of trouble for it in the future. That's what the Throne angel who came down to my fiefdom told me.”

“That is of course-”

“Oh, sure,” Lloyd interrupted without giving Gabriel a second to defend himself. “I know where you are coming from. I already heard about the potential the Jewel has to leak sensitive secrets about Heaven. Doesn’t that make the problem even worse? Why wasn’t I warned during the initial phase of the construction when the Jewel is highly illegal to build?”

Gabriel was speechless. Lloyd was the one who constructed an illegal building, so he was in the wrong here. However, he was also the one raising his voice now. What was even stranger was that Lloyd made perfect sense!

Lloyd’s voice grew more confident. “I say this is a problem. You said the Jewel was outlawed and under strict regulation. If that was the case, shouldn't you have popped up just as I was about to build it, saying, ‘You can't do that, my friend!?’”

“Young man, you see-”

“No, I’m not done yet,” insisted Lloyd. “Do you see how wronged I was? I had no idea. Nobody told me about any of this. There were no warnings or notices. So, how was I supposed to know the Jewel had been outlawed?”

Gabriel didn’t say anything.

“I’m not lying. I merely thought that it would be amazing to build such an amazing piece of architecture from the mythical ages!” Lloyd’s voice sounded like a wronged, innocent victim.

“Um, I am sorry about that. However—”

“Please,” Lloyd said dismissively, waving his hands. “Listen to me first. No one informed me that the Jewel was outlawed, so I poured all my blood, sweat, and tears into its construction. In the end, only to be informed that I was building an illegal structure and had to destroy it Otherwise, I’d be punished. What in the world is this situation?”

Gabriel readjusted himself in his seat. He did not enjoy this conversation.

“Please put yourself in my shoes. Isn’t it only natural for me to be annoyed?”

“Um, about that-”

“I would appreciate it if you don’t cut me short,” replied Lloyd curtly.

“Oh, sorry, I thought you were asking a question—”

Lloyd clapped indignantly. “Because that's how unfair the whole thing is to me. Don't you think you'd feel the same way if you went through something similar? I’m sure you’d complain too.”

This time, instead of replying, Gabriel remained silent, for he didn’t want to provoke Lloyd again.

“Answer me, please,” demanded Lloyd irritably.

“Can I... give you an answer now?” asked Gabriel carefully.

“Yes, Your Grace.”

“Whew. You are an unusually difficult person to deal with,” confessed Gabriel as he sighed.

“I’d appreciate it if you said I was assertive instead.”

Gabriel ignored the suggestion. “What are you going to do if you get on my bad side from how you're behaving right now?”

“You promised that it won’t happen,” reminded Lloyd with a smile.

“Whew...” sighed Gabriel again as he laced his hands on the desk. “I regret giving you that promise.”

“Promises are meant to be kept.”

“And that is why I am regretful.” Gabriel held back a bitter smile. He couldn't believe that this sort of person even existed. However, Gabriel understood where Lloyd was coming from. “So, you're arguing that the demolition order was issued too late. Am I correct?”

“That is exactly my point.” Lloyd gave a nod. He could tell his strategy was working. He forcefully pushed forward his point with an aggressive tone to address his current situation. He then moved on to the topic he had in mind as soon as he got the impression that his plan was working. “I have no plans to object to your decision. I am confident there’s a reasonable justification and explanation for it. So, I don't think the decision is inherently unfair. It’s just that...”

“Just what?” Gabriel echoed when Lloyd paused midway.

Lloyd locked his gaze on Gabriel's. “I’d like to stress that the issue at hand is the lack of advance notice or warning from Heaven, which only came through seconds before the Jewel’s completion. This administrative blunder brought me great harm despite the fact that I had done nothing wrong.”

“Hmm. Harm, you say,” mused Gabriel. “Can you cite a specific example to prove your point?”

“Of course.” A corner of Lloyd’s lips rolled upward. “First, the construction of the Jewel of Truth and the dam required massive amounts of capital and labor, and more than anything else, time was the greatest expense out of everything.”

“Time, you say?”

“Time,” affirmed Lloyd. He was being genuine here. Speaking truthfully, he added, “First, I would like to disclose my reason for building the Jewel of Truth. It was to stop the restoration of destiny.”

“Hmm, I see. Keep going.”

“Yes, thank you,” expressed Lloyd heartily. “I was forced to travel around various parts of the continent to collect all the key materials for the construction, from the Mermaid Kingdom in the Arctic Sea to the City of Magenta, to Tyrannus’s ice cave, and to the Great Plains of Klamath in the Northwest. I even had to take a trip to another dimension.”

“That...must have required quite a bit of effort,” empathized Gabriel.

“Not just effort,” retorted Lloyd. “The amount of time it required was ridiculous, too. That was what I spent all my time on while trying to find a way to stop the restoration of destiny.”

Originally, Lloyd’s plan was to present his case in a calm and collected manner. But as he spoke on, a wave of anger surged in him.

“And yet?!” Lloyd bawled indignantly. “After wasting my precious time going through all the trouble of traveling around the continent, I succeeded

in collecting the key materials for the construction. And just as I was about to build the Jewel of Truth and discover how to stop the restoration of destiny... Bam! A Throne angel appears and tells me that I should destroy my work."

"Hmm, that is..." Gabriel broke off.

"What do you say now that you're hearing it from me? It crossed the line, yes?"

"..."

"That's my exact point. "You should have notified me when I was collecting the Jewel of Truth. But in reality, you didn't. So, as a result, I am forced to demolish the Jewel of Truth that I built to stop the restoration of destiny before accomplishing the goal."

This time again, Gabriel said nothing.

"All my money, time, and effort until now has been for nothing. Not a single thing. The opportunity cost of it all is also equally immense. My life has been ruined. And it's all thanks to you for not providing an advanced warning before ordering a demolition." Lloyd let out a heavy sigh.

Gabriel suddenly felt a prickle of guilt. "Umm... Are you saying that you want to be compensated for your investments because of the lack of notice?"

"Yes, Your Grace, that is exactly my point," Lloyd said, looking up and nodding firmly. "The matter has been keeping me up at night. My investments have been wiped out, and I'm about to face the full wrath of destiny. Where should I express my grief now? Right here. To you. Who else other than the just and merciful Minister of Angels?"

"I, of course—"

"Yes, you don't have to say it. I know who you are. You are the angel who oversees all the creatures of the mundane realm, such as me, with your

endless grace and kindness. So, I beg you. Please save me just this once. Please?" Lloyd clasped his hands together.

"But save you how?"

"Please agree to the conditional demolition of the Jewel of Truth."

"Conditional... demolition?" asked Gabriel.

"Yes." Lloyd realized his time had come. In a serious and bold tone, he replied, "As I have told you a while ago, I don't object to outlawing the Jewel of Truth. I trust that there is a reasonable justification behind this decision from Heaven. As such, I give my full support to the demolition order. I plan to abide by it. That is the rule, after all."

"But so?"

"I would like to request a probational period on the demolition order, given that I already spent a great deal of time on the Jewel because there was a lack of advance notice about its illegal status."

"A probation period?" This was something Gabriel didn't expect to hear.

"Yes." Lloyd's voice softened. "I'm asking you to provide a probational period for the demolition until I can stop the restoration of destiny for good."

"Hmm," mused Gabriel, "You are asking me to prevent the work you put into the Jewel of Truth from becoming a loss for the reason you constructed the building in the first place."

"Yes." As the conversation progressed, Lloyd was relieved that Gabriel was a quick-witted man, fitting his ministerial position. Lloyd then continued with his hands clasped together as if he was praying. "Dear just and merciful minister, who works all day and night to maintain the order and betterment of the world. I beg you to ensure that this menial creature from the mundane realm is not harmed as a result of the heavenly realm's administrative blunder. Please have pity on me... And another thing..."

Gabriel lifted his brow. “One more thing?”

Lloyd nodded.

“You have another demand?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded as if that would be obvious. Adding a tablespoon of shamelessness to his desperate prayer, he asked, “I would like to request just one more condition.”

“Why is that?”

Lloyd reasoned, “The probational period is simply a way to protect the investments I have put into the Jewel so far. What I would like to request now is compensation for the damage I’ve experienced.”

Gabriel’s brows lifted higher with dismay. “Are you saying that there’s more damage than what was discussed so far?”

“Yes,” affirmed Lloyd as he gave a nod. “Emotional damage.”

Gabriel couldn’t believe this.

“I was forced to come to Heaven and speak alone with such an incredibly impressive individual like yourself, the Minister of Angels. I am merely a lowly human from the mundane world. Has it ever occurred to you how mentally traumatizing this would be for me?”

Gabriel, however, wasn’t convinced. “As far as I know, you met the King of Hell.”

“Goodness,” Lloyd said, waving his hand. “How can he possibly compare to you? You are the Minister of Angels. How could the King of Hell compare to you... Hah, that is complete nonsense.”

“...”

“And so, the damage left to my mental health was just as extensive, advantageous—I mean, unimaginable. The aftermath of the experience may

force me to be bedbound for several days once I return to my world. Yes, that is how great and mighty you are.”

Gabriel suddenly felt remorseful.

Noticing the blank expression on Gabriel’s face, Lloyd asked, “Minister? Hello?”

Even if he called, Gabriel didn’t reply.

“Why are you so quiet, My Grace?” asked Lloyd one more time.

Gabriel flinched. “Oh, sorry. I was lost thinking about how I allowed a scammer like you inside my office.”

This time, Lloyd didn’t speak.

“Well,” Gabriel remarked, “I have heard your senseless groveling. It was impressive. But there is one thing I am forced to admit, and it is your claim on the damage you received.”

“Ah, yes.”

Gabriel let out a sigh. “Although I am not entirely sure about the emotional damage, it is true that a Throne angel has attacked you and caused a scene. This incident also disturbed your construction. Am I right?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded his head.

Gabriel then smiled, and now it was benevolent. “Good. Your argument was valid in any case. Without a doubt, our mistake has caused you harm. As a result, I made a decision. I will accept your request.”

Lloyd’s heart started to beat faster. “That means...”

“I will give you the probational period. Not only that, I will favorably consider your other request. So, tell me. What is this additional condition?”

When Gabriel agreed to his terms, Lloyd inwardly cheered in his heart as he saw Gabriel's benevolent smile. However, he made sure to keep his lips tight, telling himself that he needed to keep his calm and refrain from acting rashly. He focused his attention on the final missing piece to his plan, which Lloyd was about to finally obtain from Gabriel.

“I would like to ask for your full cooperation to attain the Tears of Summer, the second divine item of the House of Magentano.”

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Chapter 332: Conditional Agreement (2)

There was only one place in the world where time flowed normally. It was Frontera County, which had been able to enjoy having a sunny morning every day for the past few months thanks to that fact. Today, however, a different kind of light erupted in the fiefdom's corner.

Fwoosh! A brilliant ray of light enveloped his bedroom. However, it didn't stay for long. The moment lasted about the same time as someone taking a shot of soju or secretly reading a text message during class. When the flash of light disappeared, it left behind two people in the quiet bedroom. Lloyd and Javier.

"Haah..." Lloyd exhaled as he surveyed his surroundings. He was familiar with this room and bed. The corners of his lips jerked upward into a smirk as he realized he was in his own bedroom.

I'm safely back and successfully got what I wanted.

Lloyd's thoughts returned to the event, specifically his meeting with Gabriel, his bold suggestion, and the angel's reaction. And...

"Judging by your smile, I am guessing your conversation with the Minister went well," came Javier's voice. After being jolted out of his reverie, Lloyd quickly turned to the side. He found Javier staring at him intently. "You have appeared to be in a very good mood for a while now, Young Master. I figured your negotiations with Gabriel went well, but I was afraid to ask because we were escorted out by a few angels."

"Were you concerned that I'd get in trouble because of your question?" asked Lloyd, assuming Javier's intention.

"I did."

"Well," Lloyd grinned casually as he perched on the edge of the bed, "The talk went extremely well. I nearly got everything I desired."

“Is that so?”

“Yup. And now, we’ll head to the capital to obtain the Tears of Summer.”

“Excuse me...?” muttered Javier, taken aback.

“The Minister of Angels agreed to help.” Lloyd grinned again, more brightly this time. His mind flew back to his negotiation earlier as he conversed with Javier.

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“I would like to ask for your full cooperation to attain the Tears of Summer, the second divine item of the House of Magentano.”

“Come again...?” Gabriel's face crumpled, and he cocked his head to the side, shooting a glare at Lloyd. He seemed to think Lloyd had gone mad after hearing his ridiculous words.

Lloyd, on the other hand, only opened his eyes wider without a hint of a smile on his face and spoke to Gabriel in an even more serious tone than before. “It is just as what I said. I need the Tears of Summer, the divine item of the House of Magentano. This is why I need the help from you and the heavens.”

“Are you asking for my cooperation to help fulfill your greed?”

“I am,” Lloyd replied, nodding in a serious and brazen manner. “You admitted it a moment ago. I was harmed while Raphael forcibly tried to carry out the demolition order from Heaven. I was almost killed after being hit in the head. Moreover, the perpetrator wasn’t a demon, a murderer, or a robber. It was an angel. Do you know what this kind of act is called in our world?”

“Could you mean attempted murder?” guessed Gabriel.

“Thank you for understanding me so well, Your Grace,” replied Lloyd, “You are right. It was an attempted murder. Otherwise, it can be seen as a work accident... As such, I believe I am not asking for too much here.”

“Your condition is to receive help in obtaining this divine item from the royal family?”

“Yes.” Lloyd gave a nod.

Gabriel sighed. “Angels do not help creatures of the mortal realm for trivial reasons.”

“This isn’t a trivial reason. It’s a form of compensation for the damage incurred while an angel carried out his job.”

“At the end of the day, you are demanding help from us just like everyone else,” rebutted Gabriel.

“I am not requesting for anything big. You would just need to give a slight nudge, a little push to my plan. That is all.”

“Push?”

“That’s all that I need.”

Gabriel considered for a second. “What kind of push?”

Okay, it’s working, Lloyd told himself. When he saw Gabriel knit his brow in curiosity, Lloyd immediately threw a question back at him.

“Um, will you please lend me your ears for a moment?”

Gabriel nodded.

Lloyd walked nearer to Gabriel and whispered, “So, the plan is... When I am in the audience with the queen... Descend... This and that... That’s all you have to do.”

When Lloyd finished, Gabriel moved back slightly.

“How does that sound?” asked Lloyd, expectant.

“How does that sound?” Gabriel replied with a straight face. “Are you asking for an angel to lie right now?”

“Oh, my. Not at all,” Lloyd hurriedly added. “No one has to lie here, Your Grace.”

“How could that be? How?” inquired Gabriel, unconvinced.

“All you have to do is agree to my request right now. With that, no one would have to lie for my plan to work. Isn't that true?”

Gabriel’s face hardened. He knew very well that Lloyd was right about this.

He is right. The angel doing the job for him would not be lying since he is simply following my orders to help the human. But... something about this feels wrong.

Could this be why the King of Hell sought after this human? Gabriel locked his gaze on Lloyd for a long moment. "Human Lloyd Frontera, do you not realize that your attempt to control Heaven’s angels will affect your karma?" he asked gravely.

“I am aware of that,” Lloyd slowly answered.

“Then, why did you still make this request?”

“I have no choice.” A bitter smile appeared on Lloyd’s face. He was serious when he said there was no other solution for the situation. This plan was also the most surefire method in any case.

The only way I can attain the Tears of Summer other than this method would be by raising a mutiny against the queen. But I don’t want that. I can’t do that. If I rashly start a battle, that would be the end of everything. It would also be a problem even if I succeed since I’ll have to say goodbye to having the lazy life of a rich retiree if I become king.

It would be more troublesome for Lloyd to become king. He needed his queen, an umbrella, a shield to protect his life as a lazy bum. As such, a mutiny wasn’t even on the table.

“I have given a lot of thought before drawing a conclusion. This is the best way for me to obtain the Tears of Summer with the least amount of casualty.”

“Hmm.”

“So, please, Your Grace. I will do good deeds to balance out the bad karma that comes out of my request,” Lloyd requested in all earnestness and sincerity.

At last, after a prolonged moment of deliberation, Gabriel gave a nod. “Haah... I see. If I’m being honest, you have done many good deeds in your world. I will make an exception this time and accept your request, considering the damages you have received.”

“Thank you...!”

I did it! Lloyd yelled inwardly, but he didn't let the triumphant feeling consume him. Instead, he quickly reached into his pocket and pulled out the item that would finally put an end to the matter before Gabriel changed his mind. *Flap!*

“What is that...?”

“It's a contract, my angel,” Lloyd replied, holding out two papers he had prepared ahead of time. “One is for you, and the other is for me. It contains everything I requested from you just now. Please review the contract for any errors or disagreements you would like to correct. The content of the two copies is identical. Ah, in addition, your signature goes at the bottom.”

“...”

“I think you can write the date based on Heaven’s standard of time,” added Lloyd as an afterthought.

Gabriel felt a strong desire to hit Lloyd’s head and send him down to hell with one punch. However, he quickly dismissed the thought. It would be a mistake to hand over such a talent to the King of Hell.

“You see,” managed Gabriel. “I do not have my own signature.”

“Well, you can always use a stamp.” Lloyd flashed a big grin. Soon, the two contracts were sealed with the divine golden stamp of Gabriel the Seraph.

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“Then... Are we going to the capital now?”

“Yeah. Most likely.”

“But I have a question.” After hearing Lloyd's brief backstory, Javier frowned slightly. “How did you predict everything, Master Lloyd?” Javier asked him in a seemingly confused manner.

“Predict?” echoed Lloyd.

“The angel's reaction, I mean,” Javier explained, “I got the impression from your attitude throughout the trip and negotiation with Gabriel that you already anticipated what would happen. That is why I am curious.”

“Aha, you want to know where my confidence came from against the Minister of Angels.”

“That is right.” Javier nodded.

Lloyd brightly smiled. “How else? I did a preliminary investigation with Raphael.”

“By that, you mean...”

“To be candid, I vaguely guessed from Raphael’s behavior that the angels weren’t domineering creatures ruling over the heavens. I assumed they were the ones serving Heaven, not ruling it. So, I confirmed this for myself.”

“What did you do?” asked Javier, growing more curious.

“I simply asked if a decision from Heaven can be questioned, how likely it is for the angels to admit there’s been an administrative error, what the best

way is to make them admit their mistake, and whether Gabriel will be offended if I present a counterargument. Those sorts of things."

Lloyd then shrugged. It was true. Whenever he had spare time during the final stage of the Jewel's construction, he asked Raphael to answer a few questions for him once the latter started to live in his family's guest bedroom. The majority of his questions focused on getting more information about Heaven.

The Knight of Blood and Iron. The novel also had a brief mention of Heaven. However, it was vague and didn't have much detail. That's why I needed to double-check the information since learning more about Heaven and its minister would only be beneficial for me, no matter if I fought or negotiated with them.

Lloyd regularly went to see Raphael, even when he was tired, for that reason. In the end, he was able to learn many things from his visits.

"So, I asked all my questions to Raphael in case any of them would be answered, and he was surprisingly candid about everything. He explained that angels were public servants who could make mistakes. And Gabriel, along with all the other angels, was a humble being who readily accepted criticisms about his mistakes."

Thanks to confirming these facts in advance, Lloyd was able to draw up a broad plan and strike a successful negotiation with great results. Now, it was...

Time to work!

Lloyd buckled down to focus on a bigger goal since the heavens were on his side after their successful negotiation. He walked out of the manor, looked up at the sky, and reached out his hand to deactivate his Time Freeze skill.

Now it's time to go to the capital.

[Time Freeze has been deactivated.]

Ziiing... The notification came with a strong vibration from his manaheart. The Heart of Winter in his manaheart became dramatically more frigid, just like when he last deactivated his Time Freeze skill, but this time it was worse.

Eh... Argh!

Previously, it felt like he was pressing his heart against a frozen popsicle. But this time, his heart felt like it was wrapped in an ice pack. For a split second, his heart stopped beating, severely constructing its surrounding veins and sending a shock throughout his body.

“Argh... Ha...” The world went dark for a moment as if he had passed out in an upright position. Lloyd recovered a split second before collapsing and clutched the railing beside him for support.

The side effect from absorbing the Heart of Winter is a lot worse than I thought.

Dragon Tyrannus’s warning, which was that the effect would worsen and spread like cancer throughout his body, was accurate. Lloyd’s expression grew heavy.

The issue is more serious than I expected. I was close to having a heart attack. This is only the second time I used the Time Freeze skill. What will happen on my third try?

Lloyd swelled with nervousness. But on one part, he felt relieved.

I did the right by taking heed to the countess’s advice. It was a wise choice to divert my attention toward dealing with this side effect from absorbing the Heart of Winter.

Lloyd hurriedly got ready to leave for the capital after that day, praising himself for his foresight. Like before, the preparation process was modest and straightforward. He packed some food, clothes, and gold and silver coins. Then, he went to see the count and countess to inform them of his business trip to the capital. But there was something he had been

completely unaware of. It was the subtle sadness in the Frontera couple’s gaze toward him recently.

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Chapter 333: To Take Advantage of a Prophecy (1)

Count Frontera couldn't exactly pinpoint when he began to suppress his growing doubts despite believing that Lloyd was his son and he loved and cared for Lloyd more than anyone else.

Since when?

There is no way of knowing, he thought. It wasn’t something he could find out even if he tried. There was nothing he could do about it.

No. It might have begun on that day.

Abruptly, his mind flashed to a memory from a few years ago. It had been a night filled with suffocating despair. The stress of his crippling debt and Lloyd's hooligan ways had caused him to sigh aloud when unexpected news arrived on his doorstep. It was about Lloyd's strange construction project that was causing confusion amongst his fiefdom’s residents. Suspicious, he sat down with Lloyd at their dinner table to inquire about an odd rumor going around about him and what he was doing in the pub’s backyard. Inwardly, the count was pleading with Lloyd to stop causing trouble and start acting his age. He even revealed his prayer to the heavens. Lloyd’s response, however, astonished him.

It was completely unexpected. I was surprised.

His eldest son had always been full of disobedience. His rebellious and warped attitude had become a part of him after some point in time. But at that moment, this same son of his was shockingly calm and composed while trying to persuade him. Lloyd explained that he had a plan in mind and asked for his trust and understanding before leaving the dinner table.

Perhaps...

He wanted to believe Lloyd’s behavior that day was the miraculous change he had been praying for. Count Frontera lifted his head up to the sky. Now that the flow of time had been unfrozen, he was able to view the night sky

filled with light from the moon and stars, clouds, and shooting stars for the first time in months. And his eldest son, Lloyd, was taking a stroll beside him.

“Are you not cold?” asked Count Frontera.

"Oh, I'm good. You know, I've become a swordmaster," Lloyd grinned and said as he turned to face the count. “But, how about you? Your coat is thinner than mine."

“I am fine as well,” softly replied Count Frontera. “If I get cold, I can always steal your coat anyway. Isn’t that right?”

“Oh, that’s an idea.”

“Indeed. That’s just one perk of raising a healthy son.”

“Hahaha.” Lloyd laughed.

Lloyd's laughter prompted Count Frontera to smile back. A healthy son. Count Frontera hoped with his entire being that the Lloyd he had dinner with on that day was his son, who had finally come to his senses and turned over a new leaf. Count Frontera direly wanted Lloyd to confirm this with his own mouth.

There would be nothing better than to know I wasn’t being selfish and letting my greed blind me from the truth all along.

As Count Frontera belatedly tried to suppress the heavy sigh coming out of him, he was reminded of the floating message in the sky from the Jewel of Truth. The topic of Lloyd’s ear-cleaning habits was funny to most people, who were laughing and amazed at seeing the message. However, it broke his heart. The Lloyd he knew despised cleaning his ears and had no such unusual habit. Count Frontera sucked in his breath to suppress another sigh, and he was only able to speak after some time passed.

“So,” Count Frontera managed, “You are going to the capital tomorrow?”

“Yes, I am,” affirmed Lloyd causally, unaware of the internal chaos brewing in Count Frontera.

“I did not know Miss Bangul already made so many rebars.”

“Oh, yes. I’ve been putting some aside whenever I could. But I thought it would look strange to sell them all at once.”

“Do you mean to Her Majesty?”

“Yes, the rebars are a strategic material, after all. The imperial house may launch an investigation on me if I try selling them in bulk. It would be even more senseless to sell them abroad for the same reason. And besides, no one showed interest in buying all of the rebars at once.”

“You are right. No one did,” affirmed Count Frontera. “I contacted several buyers, but all of them refused. I would be surprised if the imperial house is interested in them.”

“I will make them buy it. It’ll be troublesome for us otherwise.” Lloyd sounded determined.

Count Frontera knew why. “You are talking about the food storage.”

Lloyd nodded. “We didn’t receive any royal assistance in the past few months while the flow of time was paused.”

The Frontera fiefdom saw a massive increase in population after it received tens of thousands of refugees fleeing from the Monster Domino phenomenon. Making things worse, he had also brought hundreds of orcs and elves over the past few months to help him build the dam and Jewel of Truth.

I’ve been depending on the Maritz Wetland and terraced rice fields to feed everyone. But we've reached our limit. Our food storage will run out soon at this rate.

As a result, the Frontera fiefdom would need quite a bit of assistance from the imperial family. But he didn't have a good reason to ask for any.

Duh. They won't even realize that the flow of time had been paused. I'd just look like I’m whining about the lack of aid that they previously sent on a regular basis.

That was why Lloyd intended to sell the rebars he had been saving in exchange for their generous assistance. This, however, was only his surface reason for visiting the capital.

My real reason for it is to acquire the Tears of Summer.

Organizing his thoughts, Lloyd gazed at the starlit sky. "Well, I'm not sure if it will work. But I suppose I have to give it a shot. Besides, since I have Draggy, it won’t be difficult for me to travel to the capital."

“Right. You have a point.”

“Yes. I also plan to meet with Julian when I get there.”

“What a great idea. Please send our regards to him.”

“Of course I will.” Lloyd suddenly remembered hearing that Julian was back in the capital with his wife after spending some time in the sultan’s kingdom following their honeymoon.

It’s the kingdom’s tradition for the son-in-law of the sultan to live in their palace for at least a year.

That was why Julian could only now return to Magenta and begin working as a palace official.

Tsk. I’m sure Miss Scheherazade has him wrapped around her finger.

The thought brought a smile to Lloyd’s face. Thinking of Julian, he added, “Don’t worry about him. I plan on kidnapping him for a day and bringing him here.”

“Now, now. You can’t do that. He finally got to start his job,” reproached Count Frontera, masking his interest.

Lloyd easily saw through him. “But don’t you miss him?”

“Well, I do, but-”

“Then, just say the word. I’ll take care of everything else,” assured Lloyd lightly.

Count Frontera zipped his mouth. While he laughed at Lloyd’s cheeky assertion, he remembered the things he couldn’t bring himself to say out loud.

Once again, a shaft of grief and confusion swept through Count Frontera as he gazed at Lloyd, his eldest son, who suddenly matured in one night and saved his entire family and fiefdom. There were days when he was so overwhelmed with gratitude that he couldn’t find any words or actions that fully expressed his feelings to Lloyd. Count Frontera felt apologetic, grateful, perplexed, and moved all at once as he stared at Lloyd. He forcefully swallowed the words rising from deep inside his heart.

I want to tell you everything, Lloyd... But I have no clue as to how I should talk to or ask you about this. I already see you as my precious son. I am grateful for you.

Count Frontera raised his gaze to the sky once more. He was at a loss for words. The sky was incredibly dark and blue, filled with light from the moon and stars, clouds, and shooting stars. He sighed as his heart filled with uncertainty and regret. Unable to distract his mind, he simply reached out and tightly grabbed Lloyd's hand. He hoped his unspoken feelings and thoughts would be conveyed to his son: Whatever you do, whatever you hide, you are my precious son that I will always be thankful for. In the cold and cozy night, they affectionately held each other’s hand.

It was a stroll between a father and son or two people who hoped that would become true someday.

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When the next morning arrived, Lloyd and Javier hopped on Draggy and left the fiefdom. Draggy carried the wrapped rebars that Bangul adorably pooped out for them. They spent all day flying until the sun started setting west from the middle of the sky and eventually became replaced by the moon. That was when they arrived in the capital.

“All right. We’re going to the capital to have a meeting with the queen, but you’re too big to come into the palace. So, what did I tell you to do?”

Clack! Clack!

Draggy made an earnest gesture in response to Lloyd's question. Lloyd's lips curled into a contented smile. “Okay, good. You gave the correct answer. Stay here and play until we return. How should you store the rebars until then?”

Clack?

“Right. That's correct. You can’t unwrap the oiled paper and expose the rebars to humidity. Do you see that flat rock over there? It looks like the perfect place to play with rebars to kill time.”

Claaack!

“Good boy,” praised Lloyd. “You’re a good boy. Go play over there. Oh, and don’t follow any strangers, even if they offer you candy. But don’t bite or step on them, either. Got it?”

Clack! Stomp! Stomp! Draggy joyfully ran forward with the rebars in its hands. With that sight, Lloyd and Javier crossed into the capital. Although it had been a while since their last visit, the city was as busy as always. The two broke through the crowds and entered the palace. Thankfully, this proved to be a straightforward process.

“Welcome Lloyd Frontera, the meritorious retainer of the imperial family and eldest son of the Frontera family, to the palace. This way, please.”

As soon as Lloyd’s identity was confirmed, the royal guards’ attitudes toward him drastically changed. One of the palace officials hurried out to personally escort him inside upon after receiving a message.

“It is a great honor for me to escort the meritorious retainer of the imperial family. May I ask your reason for visiting the palace today?”

“Oh, I’m here to meet the queen,” replied Lloyd.

“Her Majesty, Lord Lloyd?”

“Yes, I have an urgent matter to report to her. Could it be that I stopped by the palace too late at night?” Lloyd asked, just in case.

The official motioned with his hand. “No, that's not it. It's just that Her Majesty is in a meeting with a few officials at the moment, and I'm not sure if she'll be able to see you immediately... But regardless, I'll notify her of your arrival.”

“That alone would be much appreciated. Thank you.”

For a split second, the official hovered as if he had something to say. Eventually, he managed, “Um... Please forgive me, but you do not have to speak to me so kindly. I am just a lowly palace official...”

“Not at all,” replied Lloyd, smiling gently. “I insist on it.”

“I see. Please wait here for a second. Well then,” he said before taking off.

The wait time, to Lloyd’s relief, wasn’t very long. When the official came back, his face was filled with a bright smile.

“Her Majesty has agreed to see you. Please. I will escort you to her, Lord Lloyd.”

“I appreciate it. Also, did the queen happen to have a message for me by any chance?”

The official stopped and looked at Lloyd. “Oh, there was one thing she ordered me to tell you on our way to her.”

“What was it?”

Sheepishly, the official uttered, "Lloyd Frontera, even now, you only come to visit when there’s something you want from me. What a cheeky and spiteful man you are." He cleared his throat afterward.

Okay, this isn’t going to be an easy day, Lloyd thought to himself as he followed the man into the main palace with a bitter smile. After passing through countless corridors and stairs, he arrived at the palace's largest and most magnificent room, the “Hall of the Ruler.”

The hall was massive, with an oppressive amount of space. He walked down the red carpet in the center of the floor, came to a halt near the throne, and got down on one knee. “I, Lloyd Frontera, the meritorious retainer of the imperial family, am honored to be in the audience of the rightful ruler of this land.” He announced while looking around him.

Is the meeting still ongoing?

There were a lot of people in the hall. Queen Magentano was sitting on her throne, and there were dozens of people lined up on both sides of the red carpet. Among them, Lloyd recognized a few familiar faces.

That man is the Head of the House of Peers. The rest of the people here are nobles who hold considerable power in the capital.

It wasn’t an understatement to say that almost all influential officials of the kingdom were gathered here. This put a big smile on Lloyd’s face.

Perfect.

It was his natural reaction as he thought about what he was about to do from now on. His plan would be more likely to succeed with more witnesses who possessed great influence and status. This was the ideal scenario he envisioned in his head. He waited while having these thoughts to himself.

“Lloyd Frontera, raise your head,” came Queen Magentano’s voice.

Lloyd raised his head in response to the queen's command. He then prayed desperately in his heart, remembering his deal with Gabriel and hoping to obtain the Tears of Summer with the angel's help soon.

All right, Minster. It’s your turn now. Three! Two! One!

The moment Lloyd counted to three...

Fwoosh! A brilliant ray of light suddenly filled the hall as an angel from Heaven descended down with his wings spread wide open. Lloyd's lips curled in satisfaction as the officials were overcome with fear and admiration. Everything went as planned.

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Chapter 334: To Take Advantage of a Prophecy (2)

Angels. The lovely and divine souls of Heaven. Despite the widely acknowledged fact that angels promote warmth and goodness in the world, punish evil souls, and save humans, Queen Magentano did not ever believe in their existence. Not once. Never in her entire life.

Obviously. Angels? How could there be so many unfortunate mishaps, tragic accidents, sad goodbyes, and wrongful deaths in this world if angels exist?

The existence of Hell would be a hundred times more believable. This world was a horrible place. Her thoughts wandered back to her life before ascending to the throne.

She had been last in line for succession, having been born into a distant collateral family of the imperial house. But she defeated all her competitors one by one until she was crowned queen. There were all kinds of filthy fights and acts of deception that happened throughout this process. Alicia even had to get her hands dirty at times. In this period, she naturally came to believe there was no such thing as Heaven, even if Hell existed. There may be demons cursing people, but certainly no angels blessing them. In her eyes, the world was a cesspool of selfishness teeming with evil crooks and schemers. It was no different now.

Her eyes became icy as soon as the angel appeared, radiating a divine outburst of light. When the angel folded his wings, landed on the red carpet, carefully scanned the hall, and opened his mouth to speak, her hands darted to her sword. She believed that the creature couldn't be an angel, and even if he was, her sword strike would be ineffective.

Her gaze met the angel's just as she was about to act on her deathly thoughts. “Queen of the humans. You have no reason to be hostile toward me. I am not an enemy or object of worship.”

Queen Magentano stared at the angel without saying anything.

“I am here to relay the will of the heavens and nothing else.”

Queen Magentano finally removed her hand from her sword. However, it wasn’t because she was afraid of him.

Could Lloyd Frontera possibly have something to do with this so-called angel appearance?

Queen Magentano suddenly became suspicious. She had been in the middle of a meeting with her officials when Lloyd walked in and asked for an audience with her.

Since he is the imperial family’s meritorious retainer, I happily said yes. Furthermore, it’s more advantageous for me to keep him close by and stop him from getting any ideas.

The fact that Lloyd Frontera's family had become more powerful than the imperial family was kept hidden from the general public. Instead of raising a mutiny and coveting her powers, Lloyd asked for her to help him live a lazy and relaxed life as a bum. And, at Lloyd's suggestion, they quickly became political allies.

As such, she realized that it would look good on her to meet with Lloyd in front of the nobles gathered here. That was why she agreed to his request for an audience with her. In the presence of the nobles, she wanted to cement her mutually beneficial political partnership with Lloyd.

Yet, that angel emerged as soon as he appeared in front of me.

That couldn’t be a coincidence. Impossible, she thought.

Lloyd Frontera. What are you up to?

Her gaze drifted to Lloyd, who was not even looking at her. His gaze was instead fixed on the ground, his head down, and only the back of his head visible. That sight intensified her annoyance toward him, and she felt compelled to rush over and slap his chestnut-shaped head.

I am certain. It is his doing. He must have devised this entire situation like he has always been doing, racking his brain to get something out of me.

Her thoughts returned to Lloyd's actions up to this point. He was always like this, never crossing the line but carefully tiptoeing near it, displaying a masterful level of balance. And he used to get what he wanted by doing so. The most recent example of this was...

The Heart of Winter.

It was a divine item of the Magentano family. But it had become his now, though not purposefully. Nevertheless, it had become his in the end.

And yet, he shows up here to acquire something from me again as if the Heart of Winter was not enough.

Her gaze toward Lloyd sharpened. A faint, cynical smile hung on her face.

If you think I am easy prey, I may have to change my mind on you as well.

She decided to let this strange and dramatic situation play out while she figured out what Lloyd Frontera was up to. The angel spread his wings of light and walked toward Lloyd just as her eyes glowed with determination.

“Human Lloyd Frontera,” the angel said in a holy voice. “Lift up your head.”

But Lloyd didn't immediately raise his head. He couldn't do it. He needed to fix the expression on his face first.

Yes! It worked. My plan worked. So... Don’t smile. Keep a straight face.

He struggled and bit his lower lip to remove the smile from his face. But the corners of his mouth stubbornly raised upwards. His reaction was understandable, given that his plan to bring an angel into the palace had been perfectly executed.

As I expected of the minister, you are the best angel of Heaven who never lies! I knew I could trust you!

He was concerned about the possibility of Gabriel breaking his promise. However, to his relief, the latter did send an angel down to him.

Okay. Work on your face. The queen must have figured out the situation by now, but I'm sure everyone else is still clueless. I can never expose my true intentions to the officials here.

Hardening his resolve, Lloyd bit the tip of his tongue.

Ack!

The pain brought tears to his eyes, and he lost his smile. Finally, he raised his head to the angel in front of him while trying to hide his crumpled face and eyes wet from the stinging pain.

"Ded yo... Coll me?" Lloyd said brokenly.

The angel cocked his head to the side.

"Oh. My tongue... I mean, I bit my tongue out of surprise. I apologize. Please forgive my impertinence," whimpered Lloyd.

"It is... fine." The angel forcibly smiled.

Calmly, Lloyd asked, "May I ask why you have come here to look for me..."

"I am here to send you a message from Heaven."

"Excuse me?" blurted Lloyd in feigned shock, opening up his eyes theatrically.

The angel gave Lloyd a wry smile as his mind replayed the direct order he was given from Gabriel, who handed him a scroll and told him to appear where Lloyd was currently standing. The minister had explained he had signed a contract with Lloyd Frontera and needed to help the human.

Flap! The angel brought out a scroll from his inner pocket and recited its content.

“Human Lloyd Frontera,” the angel said. “You have been specially given a fateful prophecy today. You will be in possession of the ‘Tears of Summer’ from the House of Magentano.”

“Whaat?” gaped Lloyd.

“You will not be able to avoid your destiny, and it is the will of the heavens. Nothing more.”

Baaang! The scroll emitted a brilliant ray of light as soon as the angel finished, filling up the hall and illuminating Lloyd with it. Everyone in the scene became wide-eyed.

Some of the officials stared at Lloyd, unable to speak. Others covered their mouths with their hands. There were even those who forgot how to breathe at the moment. As if the angel's descension wasn't impressive enough, he made a mysterious announcement that stunned everyone. A slew of nobles, royal guards, and palace servants hushed into a grave silence.

Amid the silence, Lloyd asked with dismay, “Um, Your Grace? Please wait a minute.”

“Do speak, Human Lloyd Frontera,” permitted the angel.

Lloyd tried to look as confused as possible. “Yes, what in the world is going on? Why are you giving me a prophecy, and what does it have anything to do with the divine item-”

“It is the will of the heavens,” replied the angel on the surface. But deep down, he inwardly bawled that it was Gabriel's will, which you tasked him with. What an evil conman you are, even capable of scamming demons without a doubt. Thanks to your lie-for-me request, he locked himself in the chest of repentance. Instead of attacking Lloyd, however, the angel maintained his composure and put on an elegant act to hide his emotions with great effort.

Lloyd, on the other hand, purposefully expressed his dismay more strongly as time passed. And he prayed quietly...

Okay! Now that you've given the prophecy, it's time for you to leave now! Amen! Hallelujah! Merciful Buddha!

His fervent prayer appeared to have been answered. Or it could also be possible that the angel understood Lloyd's message through his gaze. After a quick scan of the room, the angel made a comment that effectively ended this shocking incident.

"Moreover, the people here in this realm will bear witness to the prophecy recited today. Let Heaven's will come true."

Fwoosh! Then, a divine and radiant light exploded inside the room. Everyone squeezed their eyes shut tightly from how blinding it was.

And a little while later, by the time all the officials opened their eyes, the angel was gone. They looked at each other with a look of daze from the unbelievable event that just unfolded. At last, they realized...

For the first time in the history of the Magentano Imperial Family, an angel appeared and recited a prophecy for the future. This was a historic moment.

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"Is there anything you need to tell me?" asked Queen Magentano suggestively.

"Mhm... I don't," denied Lloyd.

"Really?" She frowned.

"No, Your Majesty."

"Truly?"

"No, Your Majesty."

Losing patience, she asked in an annoyed tone. "Is that all you can say? No, Your Majesty?"

“Not at all, Your Majesty.”

“Then, why is that your only answer?”

“Ah, um, that’s-”

“That is what?” asked Queen Magentano.

“I do not know what I should say... Please forgive me.”

“Forgive you”?

Lloyd shortly answered, “Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Hah, I would not dislike you as much as I do if you knew how to keep your mouth shut.” Queen Magentano sighed deeply and studied Lloyd, who was sitting across from her at the table. “I summoned you for one reason. I would like to ask you something.”

“What is it that you wish to ask-”

“I am sure you have an idea of what already.”

Thinking for a second, he finally said, “Yes, I do, Your Majesty.”

“Then, tell me yourself.”

“Yes, Your Majesty, I have a feeling it is about the angel that descended down earlier.”

“Precisely.” A smile flashed across her face for a second and disappeared. Her eyes suddenly grew colder. “How do you explain why an angel emerged the moment you were granted an audience with me during your abrupt visit here?”

“...”

“Could this situation really be a coincidence?”

“...”

“If not, was it something you intentionally planned?”

“Your Majesty.” Finally, Lloyd spoke.

“Speak.”

“This is unfair.”

Queen Magentano was dumbstruck. “You think this is unfair?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd sat up straight, quickly giving a scan of her office.

There are three people near the queen. Two people in front of the office door. One on the other side of the wall.

They were all a royal knight. Lloyd could tell from listening to their breathing pattern...

All three of them are high-level sword experts.

Which also meant they would be suffering from the swordmaster syndrome. Which then meant that this conversation with the queen would be audible in their ears.

That won’t do.

Lloyd inwardly shook his head. This pivotal conversation between them would mark the start of Lloyd’s collaboration with the queen to actualize his grand plan.

And so, I need to keep this a secret. No one can know about this conversation between us. That includes the royal knights.

No one could know about his secret. It didn't matter if they were the royal knights or not. Because of this, no one could hear even a word of their

conversation from now on. Otherwise, the queen would be forced to reject his offer.

I'm about to strike a deal with her and acquire the Tears of Summer in return.

But if their negotiation was overheard, Queen Magentano would be thrown into a political whirlwind and regarded as a disastrous queen who struck a deal with a lowly noble to give away a divine item of the imperial family.

Anyone with malicious intentions would jump at the chance to start such a juicy scandal. I wouldn't want to get sucked into that kind of political nightmare if I were her, either. So, in that case, she would flatly reject the deal, whatever its terms are. It would be far too troublesome for her to accept.

As a result, Lloyd knew he needed to lessen the political burden this negotiation would place on her shoulders in order to pave the way for a successful negotiation. And that meant making sure the conversation stayed between the two of them.

I need to find a place for us to talk.

As soon as he reached this conclusion, Lloyd racked his brain for a solution. And, looking her in the eyes, Lloyd made a suggestion that was too sweet for the queen to refuse.

"Your Majesty," suggested Lloyd. "Do you have any desire to torture and beat me until I'm a bloody pulp?"

"What?"

Queen Magentano's eyes widened slightly, and he quickly caught the faint change in them.

As expected, it worked.

Lloyd licked his lips with a mysterious smile while thinking of an even sweeter deal he had in mind that the queen wouldn't be able to refuse.

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Chapter 335: The Shortcut to Becoming a Hegemon (1)

“Your Majesty,” suggested Lloyd. “Do you have any desire to torture and beat me into a bloody pulp?”

“What...?” Slightly widened eyes. Knitted brows. Lloyd was convinced the moment he noticed these changes in her expression.

It worked.

Lloyd held back his smile. He knew that the offer he had just given the queen was too tempting for her to deny.

Of course, it is. She secretly, no, obviously hates me. I wouldn’t be surprised if she’s wanted to hit me more than once throughout all my visits to her.

That was something Lloyd had noticed for a long time. The queen's gaze toward him had a fierceness reminiscent of a wild animal at times.

Well. I was pretty unruly toward the queen quite a few times. I’ve leeched off her without bothering to hide the fact before too. Though, of course, it doesn’t mean that she lost anything because of me.

It was the exact opposite. Queen Magentano gained countless things thanks to his achievements. But that didn't stop her from spiting Lloyd, and he was aware of her feelings. It was for this reason that Lloyd devised this plan, which involved intentionally exploiting her emotions and desires toward him. He then offered her a deal that would be too attractive for her to deny.

Lloyd rattled on, “As such, Your Majesty, I, Lloyd Frontera, would like to dare raise my sword at you at the training hall.”

She was thoroughly piqued. “A duel? Against me?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Are you challenging me to a duel?” Suddenly, the corners of her lips rose.

“Yes, Your Majesty,” affirmed Lloyd.

“Could you mean now?” There was excitement in her voice. “Immediately?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Why is that?”

“It’s my way of providing a more special response to your earlier question,” replied Lloyd, vaguely dodging her question. But Alicia Magentano was a ruler of a kingdom at the end of the day. She immediately deciphered the hidden meaning behind his ambiguous response.

“You are bothered by who will be able to hear your response here,” she guessed. “Am I right?”

Lloyd was impressed. “I am thankful for how well you understand me, Your Majesty.”

“Is this conversation something that can’t be overheard by others?”

“I ask Your Majesty to make that judgment after hearing me out,” replied Lloyd.

“How impertinent,” huffed Queen Magentano, giving a tap to the desk with a finger.

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“Truly?”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty...”

“Tsk... You always have a response to everything.”

“I am filled with gratitu... no, I mean, please forgive me, Your Majesty.”

For an instant, she wondered if he was behaving this way on purpose to provoke her into beating the filth out of him. Her pupils constricted. “Your suggestion appears to be an invitation to beat you if I can even dare do it. Did I understand you correctly?”

“How could I-”

“You have become a swordmaster. Did you not?”

Lloyd suddenly felt exposed. “You realized... Your Majesty?”

“Of course.” Queen Magentano nodded. She noticed it as soon as Lloyd appeared before her in the hall. She was amazed and stupefied by his elevation to the status of a swordmaster.

He was only a mid-level sword expert the last time I saw him. However, he became a swordmaster within a few months of our previous meeting.

She felt a sense of curiosity and competitiveness rise in her. At the same time, she was resentful.

“Good,” she finally agreed. “I appreciate you recognizing my desire to beat you to death whether you are a swordmaster or not. It also wouldn’t be right for me to turn down your heartfelt plea as a ruler of a country.”

“Does that mean,” asked Lloyd excitedly. “You will accept my request for a duel?”

“Only if you are ready to be slashed to death by my wooden sword.”

A look of horror came over Lloyd’s face.

“Let us go.” Queen Magentano stood up, her heart racing at the prospect of releasing all her stress with this opportunity. She had been under a lot of mental strain recently from managing the kingdom. She and Lloyd left her office and went to the training hall, where she ordered all the guards and their commander to stay away from the area and all the nearby premises.

Whoosh...

There were only two of them in the training hall tonight. Queen Magentano stood directly below the moonlit sky, holding a wooden sword. She laughed after glancing at the knights who had retreated far into the distance from her. “Will this do?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd replied as he opened his mobile foldable shovel. “Even if their ears are sharp, the clanging noise from our weapons will prevent them from hearing our conversation.”

“Certainly, and I’m sure that’s what you want to happen.”

“Please forgive me, Your Majesty, for only being able to give you a response through such an inconvenient method.”

“Do not be, for you can pay for your guilt with your body instead of your mouth.

“...”

“I hope your skills won’t let me down. Now, come at me.”

Step. The energy around her changed even though all she did was slightly change the angle of her foot.

Grrrr...

Her mana rotated and reverberated with the force of a powerful, seasoned fighter, filling the air with a thick energy of hostility. Lloyd nervously swallowed. The queen wasn’t anyone to look down on, as expected. It was evident that she had no intention of going easy on him.

Her intensity is on another level from Javier’s.

With Javier, there was surprisingly less pressure on him due to their enormous difference in skill. However, because the queen was only marginally better than him, the fight felt more combative between them. Regardless, Lloyd did not let himself become intimidated.

I’m a swordmaster too, after all.

Despite their disparity in skills, he believed he could manage quite well as long as he made an effort to fight with everything he had. He would at least be able to talk while blocking her attacks.

This is the only way I can secretly make a deal with the queen away from the countless royal guards who stay by her side for 24 hours a day.

The queen’s security had been ramped up ever since the assassination attempt against her. As such, this kind of opportunity didn’t come easily.

So, I must endure her attacks and say what needs to be said. If I can pull this off, my grand plan will come true. I will really be able to get my hands on the Tears of Summer.

Lloyd made a firm decision. Exactly half a second later, his new resolve was shattered with a single strike.

Fwoosh! Lloyd saw a tsunami charging at him. That was how her aura storm looked in his eyes.

Ack!!

Lloyd’s heart sank, and he instantly lifted his shovel and blasted out mana. *Boooom!*

It was only a clash between a wooden sword and a shovel. However, the force produced the same sound as an exploding grenade and shoved Lloyd about six yards backward.

Ack!

He was afraid his hands would wear away from the force. The massive impact moved through the body of his shovel to his hands in an instant, numbing his senses. The problem was that this wasn't the final attack from the queen.

Slaaash! Boom!

“...!”

The wooden sword rained down on Lloyd like an unstoppable storm even before he had been fully pushed backward.

Ack! Come on! Wait! Wait a moment!

He wanted to shout at her to stop, but there was no chance for him to do so. From that moment on, he busily moved his shovel to make it out of the fight alive.

Head! Shoulders! Knee! Feet! Knee! Feet!

He blocked, dodged, evaded, resisted, defended, and bounced off the queen's attacks. In the process, he caught a glimpse of her face.

She's happily smiling! Dammit!

While Lloyd was struggling to keep from getting hit and dying, Queen Magentano was beaming like a joyful newlywed who had just bought a new house in Manhattan.

"Lloyd Frontera," she breathed out. "Did you not request a duel because you have something to tell me in secret?"

Clang! Boom! Crash!

"Argh! Umph! Ack!"

"I am sure you did not request for a duel to have me listen to your strange grunts."

Thwack! Crash! Boom!

"Argh..! Ahh! Ack!" squealed Lloyd.

"Should I go easy on you if you're having trouble answering?"

"Yes! I love you, Alicia!" Lloyd shouted.

Queen Magentano's went wide-eyed in horror.

“No, Queen Alicia, that is!”

She felt a shaft of repulsion.

“N-no, that’s not what I meant! Your Majesty! Please!” begged Lloyd, correcting himself.

“I think I just heard something eerily absurd.”

Crack! Clang! Boom! Clang! Crash!

“Aaack! Ehek! Gyack! The thing is!”

“Speak to me softly.” Her attacks relaxed a little, but they were still lethal enough to leave a serious injury if he let his guard down. Closely defending and dodging each blow, Lloyd spoke.

“Th-the, urk! The thing is the angel back there! Emph!”

Claaang! Thwack! His words were silenced by the collision and shock waves between them. As a result, Lloyd was able to continue freely speaking without worrying about the royal guards overhearing them.

“You are right. I called the angel down to the palace.”

“What?”

Crash! Her attacks suddenly grew fiercer for a moment. Managing to closely wield his shovel to parry the incoming sword against him, Lloyd responded, “To cut the story short, I am in dire need of the Tears of Summer, one of the divine items of the imperial family, Your Majesty.”

“...”

“Ack!! Gack! Ack!!”

Boom! Crash! Boom!

“Please let me explain myself, Your Majesty,” begged Lloyd. “You will not lose anything from heeding my request, either.”

“I won’t lose anything from this? Me?”

“Y-yes... Ack! Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Continue.”

Clang! Clang! Slash! The wooden sword swung forward, aiming for Lloyd's throat. A total of 112 thrusts swept the air, with seven strands of aura glinting between the sixteen brilliant shifts. Lloyd was able to block each attack with a small step back.

Clang Clang Clang!!! Amid the shock waves that burst in series with each collision, Lloyd continued his response.

“The thing is, the, ack! It’s because of the Heart of Winter I came to possess a while ago.”

“Because of the Heart of Winter?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd leaped a little to avoid another attack. “The divine item I absorbed is slowly killing me.”

“Killing you? How?”

“Its frigid energy is slowly accumulating inside my heart. Even if I try to discharge some, it is only a temporary solution. If anything, it spreads further across my body.”

“And so, you are dying?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Clang! Clang! Lloyd gave his first counterattack against the queen after blocking all of her 112 blows toward him. His move wasn't anything spectacular, a slight swinging of his shovel. However, he was able to cover

a large area with his shovel with the help of a large amount of mana and a strong aura. *Swoosh!*

“...!”

Queen Alicia’s face hardened for the first time during their fight. Realizing that this was a duel wherein Lloyd was allowed to attack back, she held her sword up and wielded it upward. *Clack!*

The sword strike neatly cut through the shovel's force. The queen took advantage of that split-second of time to leap forward and slash into Lloyd's neck. But it was obstructed by his quick repositioning of his shovel. *Clatter!*

When the two weapons collided, Queen Magentano threw her sword into the sky, stretching her free hand, and grasped the back of Lloyd’s neck.

“...!”

Without any chance to react, Lloyd was winded by her quick knee-kick. *Thwack!*

“Argh!”

Lloyd’s body bent forward. A satisfied smile appeared on Queen Alicia’s face.

“Let me confirm whether you are telling the truth.” She immediately placed her other hand on Lloyd’s chest.

Swoosh! Swish! She then pushed out mana through her hand, quickly studying and inspecting Lloyd’s heart and its surrounding organs. The look in her eyes changed.

“You are telling the truth...”

“Please believe... Ack! Words fall short of my gratitude toward you, Your Majesty. Ugh. Haa...”

Lloyd stepped back as he panted heavily. The knee-kick he received made it difficult for him to breathe. But the conversation was far from over. He had to deafen his words with the shock waves, which meant the duel had to keep on. Lloyd pointed his shovel at the queen. She quickly understood and extended her hand as well. The sword that had been thrown into the sky fell right into her grasp.

Clang! This time, they both charged at each other. The sword and shovel collided with aura, knocking each other back a step.

Queen Magentano smiled fiercely, “Okay, I understand that you are telling the truth. But so what? Why should I bestow you this divine item simply because your life is in danger?”

"Of course, I know nothing is free in this world." The House of Magentano was not a charity. It didn't matter whether he was sick or not. Even if he was dying, it wasn’t enough of a justification to be bestowed the Tears of Summer. "As such, I have an offer."

“Tell me.”

“How about I outline what incredible benefit there is for you to give me the Tears of Summer, Your Majesty?”

“Incredible benefit?” She attempted to pierce his chest.

“Yes, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd, dodging it sideways.

Clang! Clang! Clang! Clang! The wooden sword and shovel then collided once more in series. Sweat beads that began to form on his brow splattered into the air and landed on her shirt sleeves. Lloyd's cheek was hit with the sweat droplets on her jaw. Lloyd looked her in the eyes and spoke while slowly adjusting to the style of combat between them, which involved the use of auras, something unique to swordmasters.

“If you give me the Tears of Summer... I promise to do a construction that will ensure the Magentano family’s hegemony over the kingdom for the next thousand years.”

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Chapter 336: The Shortcut to Becoming a Hegemon (2)

“I promise to do a construction that will ensure the Magentano family’s hegemony over the kingdom for the next thousand years.”

“Hmm?”

Wham! Their wooden sword and shovel resumed their violent clash, creating shockwaves and a ringing noise all around them. Beads of sweat scattered across the air at the same time. In the midst of the storm, Queen Magentano raised her brow and locked her gaze on Lloyd, who had his weapon raised against her own.

"Did you just promise me that this deal will have an incredible benefit for the imperial family?" she inquired.

“Yes, I did, Your Majesty.”

“You mean one that would be tantamount to the loss of the Tears of Summer,” she added as an afterthought.

“Without a doubt,” promised Lloyd. His voice dripped with confidence.

“But how strange.”

“Pardon me?” Lloyd cocked his head to the side.

Queen Alicia’s lips curled into a hostile smirk. “A deal that will guarantee the Magentano family 1,000 years of hegemony over the kingdom? It never occurred to me until today that you were so well-versed in bluffing.”

“Oh!” gasped Lloyd, “This is not a bluff—”

Slash! Just then, the movement of her sword suddenly became fiercer. Her attacks had come down at him in a series of short and rapid strikes before. But now, her blows had more force behind them as if they were trying to

pierce through him. Lloyd, who was about to clear her doubt, failed to adapt to this change.

“Argh!”

Thwack! Her weighty blow was like a giant's ax bent to sever its foe. Lloyd managed to raise his shovel just in time before being struck. However, even then, the world around him went black as though he had passed out. Lloyd's stomach turned at the same time, unsurprisingly.

Argh! Ack!

He felt like his stomach had been struck with a hammer at least one hundred times. His knees buckled halfway, and his back curled awkwardly into a bow. Unfortunately, he was not given the opportunity to rest and regain his balance.

“Your head will get struck by my sword if you continue spacing out,” warned Queen Magentano.

Fwoosh! Lloyd instantly noticed the second attack coming to get him.

It’s too late for me to block her sword!

Upon this realization, Lloyd flung himself forward into the ground and did a somersault, dodging her second attack by a hair's breadth.

Boom!

Before he could finish his somersault, Lloyd heard a menacing cry as the queen’s sword hit the ground and created a hole. He broke out in a cold sweat and abruptly added, “I am not bluffing, Your Majesty.”

Queen Magentano, however, continued attacking. She swung her sword from the ground. *Swooosh!*

Lloyd realized in horror that her attacks would at least shatter all the ribs on his left side if he was hit. “All I would need to do is pave a trade route in

the Pantara Range, Your Majesty!” he yelled, trying to move out of her attack range.

“What?” Her wooden sword came to a halt an inch before it struck Lloyd's left ribs. She tilted her head. “What nonsense are you babbling?”

“Your Majesty,” said Lloyd calmly. “It is not nonsense or a bluff. I am being completely serious right now.”

“You are?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Really?” asked Queen Magentano again.

“I am,” Lloyd spoke without any hint of uncertainty in his voice.

“Then, let us continue this bloody fight.” Queen Magentano chuckled, stealing a quick glance beyond the training hall. Her intention was crystal clear. The guards could potentially hear their conversation from where they were just beyond the walls. And so, they needed to continue clashing their weapons together to create noise.

Lloyd gave a weak smile of understanding. “W-words fall short of my gratitude toward you, Your Majesty...” He wondered if he'd be able to come out of their conversation unscathed. Nonetheless, he gripped his shovel tightly and got into action. He did not wait for her this time. He went after her first.

I’ll be cornered if I let her attack first!

The queen was stronger than him, and Lloyd knew that for certain. That didn’t change even when he used the Asrahan Core Technique against her. As such, he needed to keep attacking if he wanted to have some room to breathe in the fight like now. Lloyd clumsily swung his shovel in the air while occasionally attempting a sharp jab toward his opponent.

“Hmm?” Amusement appeared in the queen’s eyes. She effortlessly parried his jabs with her sword.

Clang! Clash! Clang! Clang! Clanggg!

Lloyd spoke first amid the racket. “First and foremost, Your Majesty, I have one thing to ask you. Are you aware of the length or area of the Pantara Range located southwest of our continent?”

“How dare you?” retorted Queen Magentano sharply. “Are you testing me?”

“Please forgive me, but yes...” replied Lloyd weakly.

“It runs about 430 miles long, and its highest point is Mountain Pantara, which has a height of 18,700 feet. The mountain stretches from the southeast to the northwest, slightly leaning in that direction. Is my answer good enough for you?”

“Excellent, Your Majesty,” commented Lloyd humbly. “But there’s one specific point you left out.”

“Oh, you mean the peculiar terrain of the mountain.”

“That is right, Your Majesty.”

“Must I mention every little detail like that?” huffed Queen Magentano.

Lloyd ventured. “It should certainly be in your knowledge.”

Feeling challenged, Queen Magentano added. “Compared to its towering height and length, the mountain range is extremely narrow. A mere few miles wide, it resembles a giant partition. The great height and narrow width of the range make it the steepest one in the world.”

“Excellent, Your Majesty,” commented Lloyd. “And so, the Pantara Range is also called the ‘The Knife Placed by God.’”

Lloyd smiled brightly even as he continued throwing jabs with his shovel toward the queen, who blocked all of his attacks. All the points they discussed were accurate. The Pantara Range was the harshest and most accursed mountain range on the continent of Lorasia. Its peak was at 18,700

feet above sea level and averaged approximately 13,700 feet in overall height. Despite its towering height, the range was only a few miles wide, making it dangerously steep and dotted with menacing cliffs. It looked like there were knives or potato chips placed upright across the entire land.

Otherwise, a folding screen would work perfectly too.

Of course, the mountain range didn’t naturally come to have this kind of terrain. It was said to be fairly ordinary before Dragon Kaisertus destroyed the land into its current form when he was wreaking havoc on the world one thousand or so years ago.

That’s what the novel said. And the dragon got destroyed by Dragon King Verkis later on.

Lloyd organized his thoughts with the origin of the mountain range. "The peculiar terrain and dangerous slope of the Pantara Range have become an obstacle for the southwestern region in terms of trade," Lloyd said, reflecting on his grand vision. “Isn't it, Your Majesty?"

“Indeed.” She nodded, for it was true. “Only a handful of hunters, adventurers, and seasoned merchants are able to cross the harsh mountain range at the risk of losing their lives.”

“You are correct. The only people capable of crossing the range are locals familiar with the land and season adventurers. This makes it impossible for large shipments to pass through.”

“Yet, you plan to pave a trade route here?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. There will be incredible benefits that follow if I succeed,” Lloyd tactfully changed his tone of voice while noisily exchanging blows with the queen. All the while, he never stopped speaking as he controlled his breath. “Please think it over, Your Majesty. Currently, it’s impossible to do trade beyond the southwest because of the Pantara Range.”

“Right,” she affirmed. “The only existing trade routes are the southeast and northwest roads that go around the range.”

“That is right. Those roads needlessly go on for hundreds of miles and only arrive at the southwest after passing through two kingdoms, resulting in exorbitant costs from customs duties and distribution fees.”

“Are you suggesting that your plan will solve all these problems?” asked Queen Magentano, interested.

“Certainly, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

Paving a direct path would eliminate the need for a nearly 600-mile journey around the range. It went without saying that the road, around 62 miles long, would save time and provide incredible benefits.

The new trade route would have similar economic benefits resulting from the construction of the Suez Canal or Panama Canal.

Lloyd's thoughts turned to similar examples of the situation on Earth. The Suez Canal allowed ships to travel directly between Europe and Asia without having to circumnavigate Africa's Cape of Good Hope, reducing the travel by thousands of miles. The Panama Canal on the American continent accomplished the same thing. The canal made it possible to travel directly from the Pacific Ocean to the Atlantic Ocean. There were countless economic benefits that came from these achievements. And this would likely be the same here too.

The southwestern kingdoms will be able to trade directly with us, creating an explosion in the distribution of various resources such as agricultural and processed goods. It would start the golden era of the commerce industry. The imperial family will also earn a profit from customs duties since they’ll be the ones managing the trade route.

The trade route was also advantageous from a military standpoint. It meant the queen could order a military procession into the southwest whenever she wanted at any time in the year.

The House of Magentano is already steadily establishing itself as a hegemon. They would reach new heights by opening this trade route. It's a comparable accomplishment to taking down five bases in Mooncraft right after the game starts, killing three barons in a row in the Summoner's Cliff, or having a newborn baby with an IQ of 200 who sleeps for eight hours straight without getting sick or crying. How cool is that?

The mere thought alone was dazzling. As such, this new trade route would promise a thousand years of hegemony over the kingdom to the House of Magentano, depending on how it was managed and used.

She won't be able to turn my offer down. Not a chance.

Lloyd was certain that this would be the case. This was a beneficial deal for the queen, even if it came at the expense of the Tears of Summer.

The divine item is being wasted inside the walls of the storage. But the trade route will be useful for hundreds of years once it is opened.

That was what Lloyd calculated. This was the most important part of his grand plan and what he spent the most time thinking over.

She should voice out her concern right about now.

Lloyd studied the queen's face while frantically moving his shovel to avoid being struck by her wooden sword. And Lloyd was correct. She gave him a frown.

"Lloyd Frontera, my loyal subject, your suggestion and offer are truly alluring. However, there are two things that I am concerned about."

"What are... Argh! What are they?"

Boom! Clang! Clang!

Their weapons emitted shock waves and fiery sparks as they clashed against each other.

“First,” she said in between the clanging noise. “The House of Peers will be divided over the matter because of the prophecy your angel announced today. Are you aware of this?”

“Certainly, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“Really?”

“Yes,” Lloyd said with a nod. “It was the first time an angel ever came down to the kingdom and gave a prophecy. The House of Peers will be divided into supporting and opposing factions for the prophecy.”

“That surely will be the case,” replied Queen Magentano wistfully.

“Yes, Your Majesty. The supporters of the prophecy will claim that I must be given the Tears of Summer and accuse the opponents of committing blasphemy.”

“You are right,” she agreed. “And the opposing faction will argue that bestowing the divine item to a mere servant of the imperial family like me is excessive, even with the divine prophecy. They will also accuse the supporters of the prophecy as traitors.”

“I expect them to. Is that not why you are worried about me?”

“Did you... already realize this?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd, of course, had the realization early on. “You will be placed in a difficult position because of the divided opinions of the officials with reasonable arguments on both sides. This will make it more difficult for you to choose one side.”

“That will likely be the case. Yet, you are offering to take the burden of choice over this matter off my shoulders.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” It would be correct to guess that Lloyd made the offer to make the following request to the queen. “Then, please give me a test.”

“A test?”

“Yes, I would like for you to entrust me with the road construction in the Pantara Range and make a decision depending on my success.”

“You mean the decision about whether to give you the Tears of Summer?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” affirmed Lloyd in a softer voice. “Through this method, the supporters and opponents of the prophecy will accept whatever you say, as you will solely base your decision on the success of my construction.”

“And thus, it will lessen the political burden placed on me?”

“I am filled with gratitude that you understand me so well, Your Majesty.”

“Ha.” Queen Magentano chuckled. It was a clever strategy the longer she thought over his suggestion. At the same time, it demonstrated how much effort Lloyd put into devising such a scheme. “Are you saying if you succeed, the opposing faction will accept giving away one of the divine items of the imperial family as a new trade route would be just as valuable? But even if you fail, the supporters of the prophecy would accept my decision since it demonstrates that you are unworthy of receiving a divine item.”

“Precisely, Your Majesty,” answered Lloyd as he clanged away the wooden sword wielded at him and thrust his weapon at her.

She will take up the offer. This is a complete win for her.

She had nothing to lose here. If Lloyd successfully completed the construction, she would obtain a golden goose for the small price of giving up the Tears of Summer. If he failed, she would not gain a new trade route but would not lose the Tears of Summer either. In both cases, there would be no loss on her side, and Lloyd displayed a transparent attitude toward the queen to further this point.

That is why I naturally revealed to her that I obtained the Heart of Winter rather than say I lost it. I figured she'd sensed that part already with her

quick wit and expertise in political strategy. I decided that concealing the truth from her and making an excuse would make her lose trust in me.

That was why he openly told her about absorbing the Heart of Winter. That his life was at risk due to the side effects of having the divine item inside him.

The result of our conversation wasn't too bad.

And she naturally accepted his subtle confession, which confirmed that it was already on her mind that he had taken the Heart of Winter.

So, she will understand my intentions by now.

Lloyd was confident. But his intention must have been too plain.

Queen Magentano smirked meaningfully. "Ha. How insolent."

Thwaaack!

Right after she blocked Lloyd's shovel jab, she extended her hand and grabbed Lloyd's neck.

Thump!

She tightened her clench and strangled him. She put on a deathly smirk. "Are you trying to tempt me with an offer that I would lose nothing from?"

Lloyd coughed harshly. "Did you notice?"

"Of course." Her ghastly smirk turned wry. "But I understand enough that your offer is appealing regardless. Now, I will voice my second concern."

"Please do so, Your Majesty," Lloyd muttered.

"I will. You must have pegged me and the imperial family a fool. However, the House of Magentano has already made multiple attempts in the past to construct a trade route in the Pantara Range."

“I am well aware of that,” panted Lloyd.

“You are?” She raised her brow.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Then, you should be aware that every single one of the attempts failed.”

“Of course, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“So, how can you be so confident that your attempt will end in a success?”

“I see a way to succeed, Your Majesty.”

“A way?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Speak.” Her eyes flashed icily. It seemed to test Lloyd’s veracity.

Lloyd, on the other hand, was unfazed. “Yes, Your Majesty. I will successfully carry out the construction through...” Lloyd out a breath as if he had anticipated her reaction and question. His response was confident and unreserved like a seasoned teacher providing the solution to a question on the SAT. “Building a narrow-gauge railroad with loops and switchbacks.”

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Chapter 337: The Shortcut to Becoming a Hegemon (3)

The Pantara Range, located southwest of the kingdom, was an impassable natural barrier with several layers of steep cliffs. In addition to its rocky terrain, the land’s climate was harsh. Its weather was erratic, and there were frequent blizzards that came without warning.

But the land was far too valuable to be neglected. A trade route that cut through the range would bring massive benefits by saving the time it took to go around it instead. All of the former monarchs of the House of Magentano believed that this trade route would elevate the kingdom's status. As a result, they expended enormous effort to build a road through the range. A total of nine monarchs attempted the construction. But they all failed for one simple reason.

There were too many technical difficulties. With the royal developers’ civil engineering expertise, all they could even attempt to do was lay down a plank road.

Queen Magentano bit her lips tightly. Plank roads were used as a way to build a path on top of steep cliffs. The first step to build one was to dig holes in the ground for the stakes that would be placed down next. Once the stakes were inserted, planks would be laid on top of them. This process was repeated until a plank road appeared along a cliff.

But there were too many issues with the road.

She recalled the nine kings before her who attempted the construction and their reasons for failure.

A plank road could be built one way or another. However, it was impossible to maintain one. The wooden planks and stakes would begin to rot and crumble after two years of repeatedly getting soaked, freezing, and then thawing out in the range’s harsh climate.

The durability of the road quickly deteriorated in the harsh climate. Even with meticulous maintenance, it became unusable after two years. The

structural limitations of the plank road itself also stymied the previous monarchs' plans.

The road was too narrow for more than one person to pass through. So, it didn’t have the capacity for a large number of people or shipments to travel at the same time even if it was built. There were also disastrous occasions when the road collapsed from being forced to carry multiple loads.

That wasn't the end of it. Once someone was on the road, it was impossible for them to change routes or turn back to where they came from. The road was too narrow, with a stone wall on one side and a cliff on the other.

Thus, the road was impossible to use as a trade route. It was a failure.

Thus, one of the previous monarchs had dared to make even bolder attempts.

The monarch attempted to widen and strengthen the road with metals. However, it failed because there was no way to transport the large and heavy construction materials while withstanding the range’s harsh climate. The plan led hundreds of laborers to die in just two months. Ultimately, the construction was eventually halted.

This was a summary of the former monarch’s past efforts. The House of Magentano had given up on building a trade route through the range after the last failure. They simply couldn’t carry out the construction with their current capabilities.

But what? Narrow gauge railroad? Loops? Switchbacks?

Queen Magentano jolted herself awake from her trance. A narrow gauge railroads. Loops. Switchbacks. All of these terms were new to her. Her expression toward Lloyd darkened, and her grip on his neck tightened. “Give me a more detailed explanation.”

Crunch!

“Weck...!” Lloyd squealed like a pig and helplessly stared at the queen. He then fumbled to point his finger at his neck, indicating that he was nearly suffocating and couldn't speak. His resistance caused her to realize her mistake and flinch, loosening her grip slightly. Instead of responding, however, Lloyd wrenched himself from the queen’s grip with one hand and shoved aside her wooden sword with his shovel.

Clang! Clang! Their auras pushed against one another, creating fire sparks and screeching noise.

“Are you asking me to describe the construction techniques I mentioned just now?” asked Lloyd amidst their fight.

“Yes, I am.”

“I am sorry, Your Majesty, but that will be difficult.”

“Difficult?” She frowned. “Do you not want to explain what loops or switchbacks are?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Queen Magentano grimaced further. “Why is that?”

“For it is my trade secret.”

Slash! Kaboom! Whack! Her sword strike became instantly fiercer. Lloyd answered, barely able to hold out against the queen’s attack. “Urgh! Ack! Eek! R-really... Please forgive me, but... But you could turn down my offer if I fully explain these techniques to you.”

“Do you possibly think I will start the construction by myself after hearing about your techniques?” asked Queen Magentano in disbelief.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Her eyes flashed with a glint of anger.

Crash! Clang! Thwack! Even though her sword strikes became more powerful, Lloyd was able to block them more effectively. Despite that, he put on a bitter smile at the same time.

I can't tell her too many details about the construction methods I planned to use. Though I doubt she'd do something as low as stealing my ideas, you never know what could happen.

He knew what their relationship was. They weren’t family or friends. They weren't comrades who looked out for each other. They were merely cooperating together as strategic partners with aligning interests.

So, even if I'm close to her, I should keep my distance. We're bound to end up in a muddy, messy fight the moment one of us gets too comfortable with the other.

They needed to establish a firm boundary and clearly outline their mutual interests and rights. This was the reason Lloyd refused to reveal his construction methods to her. It was also why he had never suggested this project to her until today.

I actually had this construction in mind before, but I had no particular reason to do it for her.

Lloyd had always known about the importance of this construction since the novel mentioned it three or four times as a long-held ambition of the House of Magentano. But Lloyd didn't bring it up or suggest it to her before because he didn't see the point of it.

Lloyd thought his course of action was obvious. After all, this was a major bargaining chip for him. He had been trying his best to avoid using it prematurely. Lloyd believed that this project would give him the upper hand in a future negotiation with the queen. That was why he finally revealed his trump card today to obtain the Tears of Summer.

Plus, this construction is feasible. I can get it done. A similar construction happened back in my world.

Lloyd suddenly recalled the narrow-gauge railroad back on Earth. It was the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway in India.

I think it was around 1870 when the United Kingdom colonized India. The British and their love for black tea. Those fanatics of black tea had the tendency to take out their wallets the moment they saw a good area to grow tea leaves wherever they went.

Coincidentally, a region known as Darjeeling piqued the interest of the British. The altitude was about 6,800 feet, and it was in the tropical plateau area, covered in thick fog all year because the warm air from the Bay of Bengal met the Himalayan mountains. The temperature difference in the day and night also created ideal conditions for growing high-quality black tea leaves.

That was why the British began to concentrate on Darjeeling, which was scarce at the time. They reasoned that establishing a black tea field and hiring thousands of laborers would yield enormous profits for them. However, they needed to build a road that would let them transport large amounts of goods and black tea leaves out of the field. But they realized the range had a rough terrain.

As a result, those tea-loving people built a railway in the mountains instead of using the existing carriage road, which took five to six days to travel one way. The goal of their construction was to create a way to safely transport bulks of goods and laborers between regular intervals of time.

The railroad was about fifty-four miles long, spiraling into the mountain. What was shocking was its extremely narrow gauge.

The “gauge” referred to the distance between two rails. South Korea adhered to the global standard interval of 4.7 feet. Countless trains, including the KTX, were built to operate on a narrow-gauge railroad of the same size. The one built by the British in Darjeeling, on the other hand, was only twenty-four inches!

Because it had to pass through the rugged and difficult mountain terrain, the scale of the construction and size of the train would increase if they

tried to lay down wide tracks like a standard gauge railway. The project would also become more dangerous and difficult with it. As a result, they reduced the size of the gauge and train as much as they could without affecting the railway's ability to transport goods.

The British civil engineers then incorporated two more railway features on top of what they already had.

Thanks to these additions, they were able to install the railways across the steep terrains of the mountains without having to create almost any tunnels. The construction also took significantly less time than it would have otherwise. They were able to build an efficient and cost-effective supply transport route.

The outcome of the construction was the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway. Lloyd thought of creating a similar railway through the Pantara Range.

It's more than possible. I can get it done.

Lloyd was confident. It was all thanks to completing his research on the matter early on.

I looked through the Magentano construction records a long time ago and learned several things, such as how the main path along the mountains to set down the railway would be thirty-seven miles long and what the roughest and harshest areas of the range are.

Lloyd's research became the basis for his confidence and conviction. Not willing to reveal what he learned through his preparation process for free, Lloyd answered, "At any rate, please forgive me, but this is a trade secret that I keep to myself. As such, please make a decision, Your Majesty."

"Take it or leave it?"

"Yes, Queen Alicia," acknowledged Lloyd humbly. "For the House of Peers will call for me."

"I'm sure they will," she agreed. "Due to the prophecy from the angel."

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd was relieved that the queen was quick-witted. He didn't have to explain every little thing to her. She was able to see through his intentions, which made the conversation flow much easier. “I expect the House of Peers’ request for my appearance to arrive in three or four days,” Lloyd said brightly. “As Your Majesty stated, it will be due to the prophecy.”

“Yes. They will barrage you with various questions at the hearing. The proponents will try to prove the prophecy's legitimacy through your testimony, while those in the opposing faction will search for any flaws in your words and attitude to prove its invalidity.”

“Yes, that will be the case, Your Majesty.”

“Then,” Queen Magentano summarized. “You are saying that I should make a decision and act on it on the day of your hearing if I am to take up your offer. Is that what you mean?”

“That is exactly the case, Your Majesty.” Lloyd nodded.

“I see you are giving me some time to think.”

“I am overwhelmed that you take it that way.”

“Overwhelmed, my foot,” she huffed. “I can clearly see how you are struggling to avoid getting knocked out by one of my blows.”

Boom! Clang! Clang! Clang! It was true. Despite the fact that Lloyd was talking and explaining a lot, his body was flailing and dancing around to dodge her attacks in any way possible. She laughed at the sight.

“I see... I suppose this is enough training for today.”

Wham!

“Argh!” The blow, which felt like the icing on the cake, a finale, swept the space with incredible force. Despite his defense, Lloyd's feet slid back about ten yards. But he had a smile on his face. “Whew... Ha... Whew... Word cannot express how grateful I am to you, Your Majesty...”

“Gratitude, my foot.”

“...”

“I understand your intentions. I shall see you again on the day the House of Peers calls for you.”

“Then, as for my offer-”

“I will think about it until then,” she interrupted.

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd.

“Keep looking for that gratitude, and we shall be training again,” warned Queen Magentano.

“The time is late, so I will take my leave now, Your Majesty.”

“Suit yourself.”

Lloyd bolted after paying his respects and dashed out of the training hall before she changed her mind.

Now that she was alone in the hall, Queen Magentano weighed Lloyd's suggestion. It sounded appealing. And, without a doubt, profitable. At the same time, it was so ridiculous that it made her laugh.

What an amazing and outrageous man Lloyd is.

The more she thought about him, the more she laughed aloud. Lloyd was incredibly unpredictable. And he was even more remarkable than she had imagined.

“I did not know that he was already approaching my level...” Queen Magetano's gaze shifted to the exit of the training hall. Her wrists were trembling faintly from how sore they were, in contrast to the casual and carefree demeanor she displayed throughout her training with Lloyd.

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Chapter 338: Chewing Up the House of Peers (1)

Lloyd had been relaxing for the past two days, lounging around his guest room in the palace. But he wasn't waiting for the queen's response to his grand offer, imagining a greater future for himself, nor coming up with a smarter ruse with his political insight by studying the atmosphere of the palace.

“Ouch... Argh... My back,” groaned Lloyd.

“Does it hurt here that badly?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, and the other side too. Yes. There.”

“Then why did you duel Her Majesty without any plan...” Javier kneaded Lloyd’s sore body.

“Ouch!” screamed Lloyd. “Easy! Like I wanted to do it.”

Lloyd screamed in agony on his bed. He was not exaggerating. Every part of his body ached and throbbed with excruciating pain. His joints and muscles felt like they had been separated into individual pieces and randomly jumbled together again. Lloyd remembered the person who was responsible for his hellishly sore muscles.

Ha. I thought I protected myself from all of her attacks.

He appeared to be doing it for real. Lloyd believed he put up a good fight when considering that it was a fairly long and intense duel against none other than Queen Mangentano, a formidable swordmaster. Despite her endless attacks, only a few of them directly landed on him.

There were only two direct blows, which were when she kicked my solar plexus with her knee and strangled me by the neck.

So, Lloyd was satisfied. He thought he did an amazing job fighting against Queen Magentano, who was basically a human weapon and arguably the

second strongest person in the world after Javier.

But I was wrong...

It was fine even as he came back to his chamber, washed up, and slept with a satisfied glow. But the next morning, he realized that the aching muscles he received from Queen Alicia were far worse than an aching tooth or head.

It was delusional of me to think I did a good job.

As soon as his eyes opened in the morning, he felt like he'd been beaten down with a hammer. He was unable to get out of bed. Every inch of his body was in pain as if he'd been in a car accident.

Just blocking her attacks put a heavy strain on my body.

It made sense, Lloyd thought. It would be ridiculous to expect a human body to endure the monstrous vigor she manifested. In any case, Lloyd had to spend the last two days in bed or on a sofa.

“Speaking of...” Lloyd muttered, “Can you be gentle when you remove the gauze?”

“I cannot,” rejected Javier coldly.

Rip! Javier sharply refused and tugged, ripping the gauze glued to Lloyd's back. The gauze was soaked in a medicinal herb mixture used to treat muscle and joint pain. However, it would dry throughout the night and caused searing pain every time it had to be ripped off from his back. Laying on his bed, Lloyd begged for mercy as he clawed at his hair from the burning sensation.

“Aaack! Get it off in one try if you’re not going to be gentle!” squealed Lloyd in pain.

“That won’t do, either.”

This time, after his cold rejection, Javier removed the gauze as slowly as possible, ripping out hundreds of short hair strands from Lloyd’s back.

“Ack! Yack! Eek! Hey, you!” Lloyd suddenly half-rose from his bed and faced Javier.

“You were not about to curse at me, Young Master, are you?” casually asked Javier.

“Of course I was!” huffed Lloyd indignantly.

“But I will still not change my method,” defied Javier.

“Why not?!”

Javier shrugged. “The physician offered a few words of assurance to me yesterday.”

“What did the man say?!”

“That it is better to slowly rip out the medicinal herb mixture dries out and hardens the gauze.”

“Better for what?!”

Javier met Lloyd’s eyes and grinned. “Better for improving mood.”

Lloyd gaped in disbelief.

“Looking at your reaction now, Master Lloyd, I see what the physician meant. Surely, he is an amazing physician of the imperial palace.”

“Hey!” bellowed Lloyd, “Amazing, my foot. You are lying about him, aren’t you?”

“Ah, you got me.” Javier then gave a tug, slowly this time as well.

“Ouch!!!”

Lloyd fell flat on his bed in pain, and Javier guffawed in amusement. But the laughter didn’t go long.

“But Master Lloyd,” called Javier gravely.

“Yeah.”

“I have a question.”

“Not answering you.”

“...”

“Properly remove the transdermal patch... I mean gauze, and I’ll talk. What is it? What are you curious about?”

Javier said, “It is about the rumor that has been circulating around the capital for the past two days.”

“Yeah.”

“I heard the rumors say an angel descended during your meeting with the queen and delivered a prophecy. Is that true?”

“Yeah.”

“And that the prophecy was about bestowing the Tears of Summer to you?”

“Yeah.”

Javier gulped. “Then, the thing you agreed upon with the Minister of Angels back then was...”

“You are right,” affirmed Lloyd. “That was it. That was what I asked for to the Minister of Angels.”

Javier sighed.

“What? Why? What? Why are you narrowing your eyes like you have another complaint?”

“It is not that. I am simply dumbstruck,” remarked Javier.

“Dumbstruck?” Lloyd frowned.

“First, let me say that I will not nag you about something a trivial matter, like how you perverted the angels into some sort of demonic existence. Even if I do, you won’t change anyway. But what I want to say to you is-”

“What?” Lloyd urged.

“If it was your intent was to strike a deal with Gabriel to deliver a prophecy for you, you should not be just lying around like you are now.”

“Hmm. Why?”

“It is not the time for you to be lying around, as I said.” Lloyd was lying on his stomach, so Javier couldn't see his expression. But he could see this young master smirking like a devious pervert, as he always did when he had a sly scheme in mind. “The entire capital is in uproar,” he said solemnly. “As a result of you and your prophecy.”

“Why? Did a fight break out or something?”

“Yes.” Javier nodded. “The capital is divided into two opposing groups.”

Lloyd wasn’t surprised. “Let me guess. On one side, there are those who insist on following the prophecy and giving me the Tears of Summers. But on the other side, there are those who argue that thoughtlessly handing over one of the divine items of the imperial family would be a poor decision. That's all there is to it, right?”

“Did you... see that ahead as well?”

“Yeah, somewhat.” Lloyd shrugged. He scowled at the sharp pain that followed from his shoulders. “When you think about it, it's kind of obvious. The absolute prophecy from Heaven, or the divine item of the imperial family. They have to choose between the two.”

“That is exactly the point,” Javier seconded gravely.

“Looks like it has stirred the pot in the capital.”

“Of course,” affirmed Javier. “From the merchants and loaders in the markets to the farmers and patrol guards, children, and nobles, everyone is divided into two groups and voices out their concerns.”

“Hmm,” mused Lloyd playfully, “What a debate-friendly culture this capital has, I say.”

Javier narrowed his eyes. Then, he ripped another piece of gauze.

“Eek!” screamed Lloyd in pain. “Hey!”

Javier shook his head. “How can you still joke around after creating this situation?”

“Well, how can I not make jokes?”

“Get yourself out of bed instead, Master Lloyd.”

“You mean go outside?”

“Yes,” said Javier in a grave voice, “At any rate, your goal is to attain the Tears of Summer. Isn’t it?”

“Well, yeah. You heard what the Ice Dragon said, right?”

“I did. He warned you about the side effect of absorbing the Heart of Winter and that you would need the Tears of Summer, which possesses the opposing nature of the latter. I am telling you this now since the public opinion has been divided in half.”

Lloyd sat up. “Are you suggesting I go around persuading people since both sides are strongly spirited about the matter?”

“Yes.” Javier gave a nod. “At a time like this, you have to draw more people to your side to achieve your objective of obtaining the Tears of Summer.”

“Well, you’re not wrong,” chuckled Lloyd, “But go deeper, and you’d know that you’re slightly wrong, perhaps.”

“Slightly wrong?” Javier cocked his head to the side.

"The more I try to campaign for myself, the opposing side will gain the same amount of influence that I do."

“Oh...” gaped Javier, finally understanding.

“Do you see what I mean?”

“I was being small-minded,” admitted Javier. “Your proactive efforts to shift the public’s opinion to your favor would be viewed as an act of greed for the Tears of Summer.”

“Yes, yes. That’s it. And my opponents will not stay still when that happens. They might even try to pin me as a traitor, and my efforts would backfire on me instead.” Lloyd forced a wry smile. It was a possible scenario. Though, of course, it was impossible for him to be considered a traitor because of his title “Magentano Carrier.”

The opposition knows that my public image will be shattered the moment the argument pivots to whether or not I’m a traitor. That’s what they’ll go after in that case.

They would not be interested in whether he is officially punished as a traitor. All they needed to do was slap the label of a traitor on him, destroy his public image, and eventually prevent him from being bestowed the Tears of Summer. That was likely what the opposing side hoped would happen in the end.

“So,” Lloyd said, “I don’t have to go and do what they so wish me to do. And besides, I’m in quite a bit of pain. This sort of situation calls for a complete rest. Doesn’t it?”

“Then, do you have any other plan in mind?”

“Yeah,” replied Lloyd casually. “The House of Peers will summon me soon.”

“The House of Peers?”

“Oh, looks like they’ve arrived right as we speak. That was a day faster than I expected.” Lloyd grinned brightly.

Javier shot a gaze toward the door. “Do you mean the footsteps coming this way?”

“Yeah.” As soon as the nod came, someone tapped on the door. *Knock knock knock.*

“Excuse me,” came the voice. “Is Young Master Lloyd Frontera inside?” The voice belonged to a palace official. When he entered the room, he immediately got to business. “Please pardon me for interrupting your break. The House of Peers has sent you this, Young Lord.”

“Hmm. I see. Thanks for delivering it to me.”

The envelope bore the words “Request for Attendance.” It was exactly as Lloyd had predicted. When the palace official walked away, Lloyd laughed as he swayed the envelope.

“Did you see that?” said Lloyd. “This is it.”

“...”

“Okay.” Lloyd clapped his hands. “Time to put on some real clothes and take off. Argh. My body aches.”

Javier became curious as to what kind of thoughts ran through this man's mind. And more importantly, he wondered what kind of mindset someone must have to calculate such minute aspects of their life. Javier's gaze widened toward Lloyd.

Seoul. What kind of life did you live there?

Just then, memories of Seoul flashed through Javier's mind. The city with musty air and a bustling nightlife. Presumably fake Lloyd's hometown. Javier became fascinated by Lloyd's life there because he couldn't understand how such a place could produce such a monster. But he didn't dwell on his thoughts for long.

“I will help. Your arm. This way.”

Now was the time to assist Lloyd and help him achieve his goal of contributing to the family. Javier ushered Lloyd to get ready and eventually hopped into the carriage that the House of Peers had prepared for them. It didn't take long to arrive at the historic structure. Lloyd and Javier were led through the building until they reached the Senate Chamber, where piercing and screeching voices greeted them.

“Come on! Count Peruza! You cannot speak that way! We have yet to hear from the very individual who received the prophecy!”

“Ha!” huffed a man who seemed to be Count Peruza. “Do you imply that there is any extra reason to hear the self-defense of Lloyd Frontera? So, what are you saying? We must gladly give away the divine item of the royal house to the son of a count?!”

“Gladly give away? You are over the line! May I remind you that this is a prophecy? You saw the angel descend down to the kingdom with your own two eyes, and delivered the prophecy, Count Peruza.”

“Are you accusing me of blasphemy now?!”

“Barely worse than when you treated me like a traitor of the kingdom.”

“Oh now? You’ve crossed the line, you fool!”

“Did you just say fool?!”

The exchange of shouts between nobles. Their plush seats and elegant attire did little to keep the place quiet. The entire room resembled a rowdy bar, which was the first thing that Lloyd and Javier noticed when they entered inside. Javier crinkled his brow elegantly, in contrast to Lloyd, who grinned contentedly.

Ah. The smell of home.

The House of Peers reminded Lloyd of a construction resource management agency where tough guys grabbed each other by the collar to get the

daily job before anyone else. As he went over his plan, Lloyd felt a sense of familiarity inside the room. The debate. Dispute. Quarrel. Clash. The schemes and tricks amidst it all. And the final result that would slam down on everyone. Everything, from his preparation to his plan, was perfect.

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Chapter 339: Chewing Up the House of Peers (2)

Woah. This is what I’m talking about.

Lloyd smiled contentedly as he looked around the Senate Chamber of the House of Peers. He liked what he was seeing, owing to the extremely busy, clamorous atmosphere of the room. Nobles of high status were arguing amongst each other as the veins in their neck popped, rendering the entire setting devoid of elegance and dignity. There was no sense of elegance in the atmosphere, and he even felt at ease there.

It’s a relief. An excessively upscale and formal atmosphere is suffocating to be in.

Lloyd's life had been devoid of anything upscale. It was true even before his parents became mired in debt. They were just an ordinary middle-class family in South Korea, neither destitute nor wealthy. As a result, his life was a far cry from one that would be described as luxurious. He didn’t have an experience that would be described that way either. This remained true in this world.

Well, I’m only a young master of a noble family in name. In actuality, I’ve done nothing but work until now.

First, he had to pay off his family’s debt. Then, he had to save his fiefdom from one crisis after another. And now, he had to deal with the restoration of destiny and the negative side effects on his body that came from absorbing the Heart of Winter. He worked for 365 days a year without any time to rest and was still working right now.

Lloyd's eyes suddenly became wet. He cursed under his breath as he wiped his tears away with his sleeves.

“Lloyd, it’s been a long time,” came a voice when Lloyd was about to be guided to his seat.

“Eh...?” blurted Lloyd, turning toward the voice that sounded young and familiar. But he saw nothing except for a portion of the chestnut forehead and orange-colored curly hair at the bottom of his vision.

“Look down,” came the voice again, and it sounded slightly grouchy.

When Lloyd looked down, he was greeted by a welcomed presence. “Julian?”

“Ha. You’re doing this on purpose, aren’t you? You don’t have to tell me that I’m short.”

Lloyd smiled awkwardly, feeling guilty.

“If you keep doing that, I’m going to tell on you to our Minister of Home Affairs,” threatened Julian with a smile on his face.

“Minister of Home Affairs?” echoed Lloyd, thinking a second. “Wait, Scheherazade?”

“Yeah.” Julian wiggled his brows. “Anyway, are you sure you are going to be all right?”

“Um, maybe.” Lloyd chuckled. Julian hadn’t changed a bit. He still had the same baby face, bright demeanor, and intelligent look on his face and in his eyes as before.

But the shyness in him has almost disappeared.

Lloyd wondered if it had anything to do with his wife or the so-called Minister of Home Affairs while he questioned Julian, “But what brings you all the way up here?”

“Why else?" Julian asked. “I was worried for you. You were summoned here by the House of Peers. That means you'll be sandwiched between the terrors of both parties.”

“Were you afraid that I would get in trouble?” asked Lloyd, touched.

“Yeah, somewhat,” Julian admitted sheepishly, shrugging his narrow shoulders. “I'm not sure if you're aware, but the capital has been in uproar for the past two days. You have no idea how much they pestered me.”

“Did they pester you during work with questions?”

“Do you think they would only ask some questions?” Julian chuckled. “My direct supervisor opposes fulfilling the prophecy.”

Julian rattled, “He pestered me the entire day about whether I heard the news about you trying to seize a divine item of the imperial family and whether you have an ulterior motive since it is simply impossible for a lowly subject like you to covet such a holy object. Otherwise, asking how I feel about the whole thing and that I'd be a traitor if I sided with my family instead of the imperial family... Blah, blah, blah... I must have received around 180 questions from the time I arrived at work until I left.”

“Ah... I’m sorry.”

“No, don’t be,” Julian said with a wave of his hand, “It’s my fault for being your brother.”

Lloyd felt a prick in his heart.

“So, cheer up, Lloyd. Don’t get discouraged and intimidated. Don’t die either.”

Another prick.

“You can do it!”

“Tsk,” Lloyd chuckled, sensing Julian's sincerity despite his harsh words. Julian had come here for moral support in case he got in trouble, and he must have had to leave his job to get here.

Plus, since it’s noon right now, he’s supposed to be at work right now. Given that his boss is on the opposing side, I can clearly see what he had to go through to get here in the middle of his workday.

Julian would not have left his office without notice, considering his dependable character. This meant that he must have decided to leave early, risking the possibility of getting on his supervisor’s bad side.

He would have had to reveal his reason for leaving work early.

That would have annoyed his boss and left a bad impression on him. Julian would have certainly been aware of this. Nonetheless, he risked it all to come here for a quick hello and give him a little encouragement. Lloyd appreciated the effort he put in to make this visit.

“Okay, bro. I'll be right back.” Lloyd lightly tapped Julian's shoulder, and that was all that was needed. Lloyd followed the guide to his seat, which was in the center, after looking him in the eyes. He understood the meaning of this seat arrangement.

Hmm. So, I’m sandwiched between both parties.

The nobles on the left gave him a friendly gaze, while the ones on the right looked to be clearly irritated. They were plainly exuding their dissatisfaction with their entire being, whether it was through the expression on their face or the look in their eyes.

So, those on the left are the supporters of the prophecy. And those on the right are part of the opposing side.

Lloyd grinned, going over his plan and happy he could easily decipher which side was which just from the atmosphere of the room.

“May I have your attention, please,” said the House of Peers' chairman. “As you can see, Lloyd Frontera, Count Frontera's son, has graciously agreed to appear in front of us today. As the Speaker of the House of Peers, I'd like to express my heartfelt appreciation for his cooperation.” Lloyd had seen this man before, the man with a chubby belly who resembled a bulldog. He politely returned the same courtesy to him.

Following that, a few formal procedures were carried out. The first was the introduction of ten nobles from each side who would represent the entire

group. They all glared at each other but didn't break out into an argument due to the separated seats. They instead waited until the hearing began. The hearing, however, turned out to be a barrage of loaded questions designed to sway the outcome in their favor.

“Nice to meet you. I am the head of the Alcante Marquess Family. Before I ask some questions, I would like to first express my gratitude to you for appearing at today’s hearing. Now, Lloyd Frontera?”

“Yes?” replied Lloyd.

“Up to this point in time, you have been involved in countless affairs, both small and big, related to the imperial family. Throughout them all, you have displayed your endless devotion toward the imperial family. Is that right?” Marquess Alcante asked gently.

“That’s right.” Lloyd nodded.

“Were there times when you felt reluctant to take action?”

Lloyd pondered. “There were many times when I felt afraid.”

“Afraid?”

“Yes.”

“May I ask for you to elaborate?” Marquess Alcante, one of the supporters of the prophecy, smiled with his eyes. Lloyd realized what he was doing.

He’s blatantly only choosing the questions that’ll make me look good.

It appeared that he had designed these questions to fulfill the prophecy.

If that’s his intention, I will happily accept it.

This nobleman was already going out of his way to portray Lloyd as the greatest man on the planet. Lloyd didn't see why he should refuse his help. “I, too, am a human. When the queen was poisoned, I was terrified, just as I was when I solved the Monster Domino phenomenon in the east and fought

the Bone Dragon. There were times when I thought I was going to die. I was afraid. But...” Lloyd took a deliberate pause.

“But?” echoed Marquess Alcante.

Lloyd salivated his lips. “More than my death, I was more worried that the foundation of the imperial family would shake.”

“Wow,” the marquess exclaimed, visibly impressed, sounding like a professor who had a student give him the answer he was looking for. He then cast a thoughtful and content look at the opposing side as if to say, “See? This guy is a fantastic, loyal subject with a bright future ahead of him. Following the prophecy and bestowing him with the divine item would undoubtedly benefit the imperial family. Are you sure you won’t give it to him?”

Once the marquess finished his questions, it was time for the opposing side to interrogate him. “Please allow me to introduce myself. I am Marquess Cordova. Are you prepared to answer my questions?”

“Yes, I am.” Lloyd gave a nod as he pushed down a bitter smile from forming on his face. If the questions from the supporting side felt like a warm bath, the ones from the opposing group felt like an icy bath.

“Lloyd Frontera, you have had an incident where you lost the Heart of Winter previously, is it right?” Marquess Cordova sharply flung a question at him.

“You are right.” As expected, Lloyd knew they’d bring up this incident. He calmly answered the question.

“Do you feel responsible for it?” The marquess continued his questioning.

“Of course I do,” Lloyd replied. In all seriousness, he was resentful of the entire situation. It still made him feel guilty around the queen, and the side effect was bothering him in a variety of ways, including right now. He expressed genuine regret for what had occurred. “I am overcome with sadness to this day when I think about it. The loss of the Heart of Winter

and one man on the scene. Although it goes without saying that it was never my intention, as the supervisor, my heart is bursting with massive regret and resentment. That is all I have to say.” Lloyd spoke with a solemn expression on his face and a serious voice.

“Hmm! Ehem! I see.” Marquess Cordova cleared his throat and finished the question as if taken aback by Lloyd's response.

Now that the icy questioning was completed, it was time for the warm bath of question. “I'm not sure if you're aware, but I get to this location every morning via the bridge you built for us. The Llo-Javi Suspension Bridge.”

“Oh, I see.”

“It has been extremely convenient to commute to and from work and home. I can now cross the river without fear of it collapsing during the wet spring season. The same is true today. I expect to cross the bridge when I return home tomorrow. I just wanted to express my appreciation for your contribution on behalf of the people of the capital.”

“Um...” Lloyd sheepishly gulped. “Yes.”

“As such, is it true that you first suggested building the bridge to the queen?”

“It is the truth,” emphasized Lloyd.

“I understand,” nodded Marquess Alcante, smiling. “I'm sure your suggestion came out of a concern for the people who faced hardship and experienced increased danger due to the collapsing of the Magenta Bridge. Is my assumption correct?”

“Yes,” Lloyd acknowledged with a shameless nod. That was not the case. He only built the bridge to make money. But there was absolutely no reason to reveal that right now.

This guy is blatantly painting a good picture of me, so I should graciously accept his support. Why would I reject him?

The thing was, Lloyd never asked them to make him look good in public. Everyone was doing it of their own free will, so all he had to do was accept it with grace. That encouraged him to be more shameless, and the voice of conscience accusing him of lying could only be silenced after some internal beatdowns. The same thing happened when his opposition fired sharp questions at him.

“Lloyd Frontera, I only have one question. During the Monster Domino phenomenon, why did you not actively take care of the monsters that invaded the other fiefdoms?”

“I, too, wanted to get rid of them,” Lloyd answered, his voice dripping with sadness.

“Wanted to? What do you mean?”

“I desperately wanted to. But I couldn't do it. Yes, I know,” Lloyd sighed for emphasis. “I know I couldn't because I wasn't strong or good enough, and it still haunts me. Sometimes, I wake up drenched in cold sweat after a night of tossing and turning...” Lloyd lowered his head.

“No, I am not speaking about your anguish-”

“Yes, I am aware that voicing my agony changes nothing,” Lloyd put in. “I admit that I am a criminal. I should have rushed to save the residents of the other fiefdom, even if it meant risking my life. But I couldn't do it. Nobody is to blame here. It all happened because I am pathetic and inept. So, I am filled with anguish and sadness. And, hah... I'll stop making excuses now. I apologize.”

A look of dismay came over Marquess Cordova. “No, this is not the time for you to apologize. I am just going over the incident...”

What is he doing?

The noble's intention was to press him with a sharp question in order to exaggerate an insignificant flaw of his and corner him. Then, provoke him with an aggressive question and set him off.

In that situation, anyone would blow up in anger and defend themselves. That's the reaction I intended to bring out...

That was how the opposing side planned to drag Lloyd into a messy fight. They elicit an emotional reaction out of Lloyd and start a heated argument with him, throwing all sorts of insults and baseless accusations at him. They believed that would be sufficient.

A messy fight like that brings out the worst in everyone. Once someone shows such an ugly side of themself, their reputation will begin to splinter even if it was excellent before.

That was their goal. To sully Lloyd's reputation by dragging him into a childish, muddy brawl. They believed that his tarnished reputation and image would be enough to sway public opinion in their favor. But the reality was quite different.

What is he doing now?!

But Lloyd refused to take the bait, no matter how intense and sharp the questions were, no matter how they triggered him with distorted and fabricated questions. He only agreed with them, even tearing up as he admitted his mistakes and reflected on himself!

He’s making me... look like I’m the trash here for asking these questions!

Marquess Cordova felt a rush of resentment toward Lloyd’s attitude. But there was something the count was completely unaware of. It was that the Marquess and his team's set of aggressive and twisted questions and provocations did no harm to Lloyd, who had become hardened in the so-called virtual South Korean gaming space where everyone cursed and swore at each other. They were also unaware of their bleak future devised by Lloyd's brazen eloquence and chicaneries.

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Chapter 340: Chewing Up the House of Peers (3)

“Yes, I am the bad guy. I never knew that the Bone Dragon would move like that...”

“Oh, but that was the same for everyone at the Termina Garden construction-”

“However, it was also evident that I did not know...”

“So, I felt responsible. Had I foreseen the disaster ahead of time, had I gone to the prophet and learned about the incident sooner! I believe the Bone Dragon wouldn’t have jumped in the middle of the capital and caused such an awful disaster.”

“Look here, excuse me, Lord Frontera,” huffed Marquess Cordova with dismay after hearing Lloyd’s continuous repentance, “I did not mean it that way-”

“I am aware,” interrupted Lloyd. “You were asking why I put myself down as a co-developer when I only participated in the construction of the waterway and nothing else.”

“Surely-”

Lloyd raised his hand. “That is the reason why I am repenting. Even when the queen generously allowed me the honor of putting myself down as the co-developer here, I leisurely engrossed myself in the waterway construction, unaware of the impending doom.”

“I did not mean it that way-”

“Yes, indeed,” affirmed Lloyd with a nod. “I must repent. I must lament my faults and lack of accountability. As such, I'd like to express my heartfelt gratitude to Marquess Cordova for allowing me to reflect on my past mistakes.”

Count Cordova was dumbstruck. This was not what he had expected to hear. What he wanted was for Lloyd to fight back. To drag him into a messy fight and make him show the worst sides of him. He wanted to provoke an emotional reaction out of Lloyd.

So... why does he keep making guilty confessions with even tears in his eyes? Why?

Marquess Cordova, the representative of the opposing faction, stared intensely at Lloyd with dismay.

Wait, is he doing this on purpose?

Watching over him, that seemed to be the case. Suddenly, a shaft of hatred came over his heart.

Ha! A fool like you can never win against me even if you're the meritorious retainer of the imperial family!

Count Cordova regarded himself as a devoted subject and patriot. He was proud of the House of Magentano's prosperity and rejoiced as the imperial family rose to power. He hoped that this peace and prosperity would last for many years to come. That was why he didn't have a fond view of Lloyd Frontera.

Fine. I admit that you have many accomplishments. But what now? How could there be an obligation to give you the Tears of Summer, one of the imperial family's divine items? It is undeniably improper for you to receive the Tears of Summer solely because an angel randomly dropped from the heavens and delivered such a prophecy!

Marquess Cordova was not pleased. The Tears of Summer was one of the invaluable divine items of the imperial family. Despite the fact that it had never been used before, just having it in their possession made them stronger.

Swords do not need to be drawn to demonstrate their strength. The mere presence of one in a sheath can be enough to intimidate an opponent.

To Marquess Cordova, the divine item was exactly that. It was a strong deterrent, so he couldn't understand why the prophecy should prompt the bestowal of the item to a lowly subordinate and hurt the imperial house.

Lloyd Frontera. I must sully that man's reputation, whatever it takes.

Count Cordova thought he had come well-prepared. He had come up with a series of questions designed to provoke Lloyd, and he wasn't afraid to distort some facts along the way, believing that these would be enough to embarrass Lloyd and set off his temper. Reality, however, betrayed his conviction.

It isn't working. He must have deduced what our plan was. What is going on inside his head that... he can keep his calm in the face of my humiliating questions?

Marquess Cordova couldn't get his mind around it. He was a nobleman whose honor and pride were far more important than his life. Lloyd, he assumed, would be the same as a noble like himself. So, he couldn't understand him. It was only now that he realized that this young man's value system was radically different from his.

Tsk. I expected them to mock and provoke me after making me come all the way here, but no. Now that I have gone through everything, I don't think I was affected in any way.

Marquess Cordova, who was across from him. Lloyd inwardly smirked as he stared at the man. It was true. Most of the questions he barraged on Lloyd during the entire session tried to subtly distort the truth about his actions and intentions in a negative light. It seemed like an extremely vicious media tactic. However, once Lloyd listened to him speak. He didn't sense that there had been any damage inflicted at all. The reason was simple.

The compliments my teammates inside a video game threw at me had more burn to them.

The questions Count Cordova had seemed to prepare in advance to obliterate Lloyd fell flat. They were nothing but soft baby jabs, which only made him enjoy the situation. And each time the marquess accused him with sharp and aggressive questions, Lloyd didn't fight back or give excuses. Instead, he accepted everything, even going the extra mile of putting on a tearful performance to show his guilt!

“Yes,” Lloyd exclaimed, “Everything is my fault. Mea culpa. I wasn't up to the task. I should have known the queen was going to be poisoned sooner. This would have saved her from being poisoned. The same is true in Cremo. It never occurred to me that the Gigatian would scale the mountain. I had no idea, which only added to the damage. I failed to evacuate the people, and the buildings collapsed and caught fire.”

“No, that’s not the answer I’m looking for...”

“No,” Lloyd said as he wiped his eyes. “I am fully cognizant of your concerns and worries, Marquess Cordova. You might wonder how such an incompetent person like me could dare be bestowed the Tears of Summer. Yes, I have the same question. I am a severely undeserving man with infinite flaws, as you can see. I am only curious. Curious why the heavens gave me such a tribulation, no, prophecy.”

“...”

“If I could, I want to dare ask the holy angels for what great reason they have placed such a heavy responsibility on my shoulders by giving me the divine item.”

“That is what we want to ask-”

“No. I am more curious. That is the reason why my heart is filled with pain and sadness! The prophecy should have been directed at you, Marquess Cordova, who is far more excellent and devoted to the imperial family than I am!”

“Ha?” A perplexed look appeared on Marquess Cordova’s face.

“I genuinely think so, Marquess Cordova. You have spent every day of your life devoting yourself to the imperial family, day in and day out, and you plan on doing that for the remaining time you have.”

“That is, of course-”

“I certainly think so, and I believe it, too, for you are a man of outstanding character incomparably better than a mere novice with some luck like me.”

“No, this is not the time for you to say-”

“I understand that now is not the time. But I'm speaking from the bottom of my heart. Truths, a wise man once said, are sharp and pointy, and they come out no matter how you cover them. The same is true for me right now. The more I try to close my mouth, the more the truth in my heart escapes and spills out.”

Lloyd’s eyes traveled around the room. “I am well aware that Marquess Cordova, Count Montego on your side, and the man across from you all deserve to be respected. How can I not? You are true patriots who genuinely care about the royal family while maintaining honor even when no one is looking.”

“Um...”

“No, Marquess. No need to act humble. With that, I...” It was as if he had an advanced motor or turbo engine attached to his mouth. He couldn’t stop the compliments and praises that poured out of his mouth toward his opposition without a break. “I think that I do not deserve to receive the divine item.”

“Excuse me?! Lloyd Frontera!” came a booming, impatient voice. It belonged to Marquess Alcante, the representative of the advocates. There was a sense of panicked alarm in his voice. “What are you on about? You've been given a prophecy! For Pete's sake, a prophecy! What do you mean you'll give it up because you don't deserve it? Do you think this is child’s play?”

“That is obviously not the case,” said Lloyd coolly.

“So, what is it? I'd like to emphasize once more that this is not a joke. It's the will of the heavens. Are you saying this with the knowledge of what will happen if you interpret or reject the prophecy arbitrarily?”

“I...”

“I'm not interested in your excuses!” he yelled again. “When you reject the prophecy on your own accord, you never know what punishment awaits you. Is it your intention to punish the royal family in this manner? This cannot be!" roared Marquess Alcante. “I will never allow such bad luck and a curse to fall on us! How dare you dismiss the prophecy so casually!”

Lloyd sighed at length, casting his head down in dismay and not knowing what to do.

Suddenly feeling guilty, Marquess Alcante calmed himself by clearing his throat. “I apologize if I lambasted you for a split second there. But, as I previously stated, you received the prophecy, and your lack of seriousness may endanger the royal house. So, with a slight sense of pressure and responsibility, I ask you to accept the prophecy. That is the only option for the royal family.”

“Wait a minute, Marquess Alcante!” protested Marquess Cordova as soon as his remarks were made. “Why are you acting as if following the prophecy is the only option here? How could you make such a treacherous statement about giving that young man one of the divine items of the imperial family?”

“What...?” Marquess Alcante’s face flushed with anger. “Treacherous? What did you just say?”

“I am correct here!” bawled Marquess Cordova. “It’s the divine item! Even if the prophecy was made, you cannot think lightly of the divine item of the royal house!”

Count Alcante slammed his fist into the desk in front of him. “But you never know what might happen if you defy the prophecy!”

“But the imperial house will suffer a huge loss by following it!” retorted Marquess Cordova louder.

“Watch your mouth, Marquess Cordova! You are putting the royal house at risk with your blasphemy!”

“Watch your mouth, Count Alcante! You're inciting mutiny so openly now!”

“Now, you listen!” screamed Marquess Alcante, unable to control his anger anymore.

“What...?” Marquess Cordova froze a second, taken back. “You listen?”

The two nobles started to scream at each other, quickly destroying the chamber room's atmosphere. Lloyd, on the other hand, smiled but only on the inside. He lowered his rising lips and put on a troubled expression, pleading with both parties to calm down and stop this. His bright-eyed attempt to mediate the situation nearly impressed the entire audience. Except for three people.

I knew that was how this man would react.

Javier sighed at length. Julian, on the other hand...

Wow. Lloyd Frontera. Seriously. I know he’s my brother, but how can a person be so despicable?

The two realized right away that everything Lloyd was doing at the time was part of his deception and plan. The last person to see through his ruse was Queen Magentano, who entered amid the commotion.

“Queen Alicia Termina Magentano is entering! Pay your respects to Her Majesty!”

The voice of the guard commander echoed across the room, freezing everyone and forcing them to bow. There was now complete silence in the room, and when the doors opened, Queen Magentano entered, scanning the advocates, opponents, and Lloyd. Her lips curled into a faint smile.

I knew it. I knew you would do this.

Even before she entered the room, she could hear what was going on inside. She realized something as she picked up on the noises, disagreements, and quarrels.

Your lies, flattery, and trickery. I pity those fools who have been fooled by you.

Her gaze moved back and forth between the supporters and detractors. She was well aware that all of them were devoted subjects intent on following her and her imperial house. She also knew that each made sense and that they couldn't find common ground in their opposing arguments.

Lloyd Frontera. You are setting up a stage for me to put an end to this entire situation.

Her mind flashed back to two days earlier when Lloyd had asked her to decide whether to accept his proposal and present it in front of the House of Peers.

I told him I would think about it.

She gave a bitter smile. Lloyd had clearly had this situation in mind the entire time. His initial plan was to present her with an avenue of mediation to the extreme clash and division that would occur as a result of the prophecy.

Is this your gift for me? Once again, you are trying to protect my political reputation and uplift my image.

If everything went as planned, she would increase her authority by successfully mediating between the two parties, while Lloyd would earn the opportunity to acquire the Tears of Summer. Depending on Lloyd's work, the kingdom would also have the opportunity to see the trade route in the Pantara region. Everyone would benefit in the grand scheme of things. She turned to face Lloyd.

She caught a faint smile on Lloyd's face in the split second her eyes met his. She realized it now. She knew what he was thinking and why he kept looking after her even though he seemed to always behave so selfishly. And so, she began to develop a desire for Lloyd Frontera.

Somehow, I am growing excited over the possibility that you may become more important to me beyond your role as a retainer.

“I hereby order…” she solemnly declared after making a firm resolution.

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Chapter 341: A Path Through a Mountain Range (1)

“I will hereby give an order.” Everyone’s attention was drawn to Queen Magentano’s solemn voice. Her gaze turned to Marquess Alcante, the supporting group’s leader. “I am aware that you are concerned about the misfortune or curse that may befall the imperial family if the prophecy is not fulfilled. Is that right?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Good. Next, Marquess Cordova. Her gaze then shifted to the leader of the opposing party this time. “I am equally aware of why you oppose following the prophecy. You must be concerned about the imperial family losing the power that comes from owning a divine item. Am I correct?”

“Yes. That is exactly it, Your Majesty,” answered Marquess Cordova.

The two representatives bowed. Her lips formed a content smile. “As I expected, my assumptions were correct. I am proud to have you all as my loyal subjects, from both the opposing and supporting sides.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty,” said both of the representatives.

“I am truly overjoyed,” she continued. “How could I not be when I have a group of loyal subjects as trustworthy as you all? At the same time, I struggled to sleep last night due to the heavy burden in my heart after seeing my outstanding subjects divided in half and fighting each other over this matter. However, I came to a decision as soon as I stepped in here. Lloyd Frontera.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd quickly lowered his head, concealing the smile that was about to form on his lips. His ears perked up.

“My loyal subject,” Queen Magentano continued. “The eldest son of Count Frontera. I would like to ask you a question. Are you prepared to receive the

Tears of Summer, as predicted by the prophecy from Heaven? No, can you demonstrate that you are prepared?”

“Yes, Your Majesty, please grant me the chance to prove myself,” Lloyd spoke confidently. He clenched his fists.

It worked. I knew it.

It really worked. He had a feeling that his offer to her two days ago was a success.

Well, the fact that she came to the chamber room is enough proof that she accepted my offer.

He then perked up his ears, waiting with bated breath over what she would say next.

“Good, Lloyd Frontera.” Queen Magentano’s gaze focused on him. “Hence, I have a proposal for you. Given my high opinion of the countless accomplishments you’ve achieved, I sincerely hope you will make wise use of your excellence for the prosperity of the imperial house and nation. I ask you to open a large trade route across the Pantara Range, which currently acts as a wall to the southwest.”

Lloyd’s heart screamed “Yes” as soon as the declaration was made, while the nobles went wide-eyed. Her eyes lit up with a meaningful smile. “This is my test for you, Lloyd Frontera, as a means of mediating the situation. I say that if he succeeds in building a trade route across the Pantara Range, he will be given the Tears of Summer.”

Clack. Clack. Her shoes clattered as she moved closer to Lloyd, who lowered his bow further down when she approached him. Her solemn voice spoke toward his chestnut-shaped head.

“How about it, Lloyd Frontera? If you succeed, you will be given the Summer Tears. If you fail, you will not. Do you want to accept my offer?”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.” Lloyd had no reason to be hesitant. He collapsed to the ground as soon as she finished speaking like a cat anticipating a salty snack on its back.

“Good,” she said, smiling contentedly. She, too, was content. She had stayed up all night last night thinking about Lloyd’s proposal and weighing the pros and cons of accepting it.

It was too good of an offer. I was rather suspicious of it.

If it sounds too good to be true, it probably is. That was the principle she had developed over her many years in the palace. And Lloyd’s proposal was too good to be true with no risk involved in it for her. If he succeeded, she would acquire a trade route that would promise the imperial family hundreds of years of prosperity in exchange for the Tears of Summer. If he failed, she would not obtain a trade route but would keep the Tears of Summer. Ultimately, she would not even have the smallest loss either way.

No, I will benefit even before then. My political influence will strengthen from acting as a mediator over the divided nobles.

As such, the queen pondered whether she should believe Lloyd’s intentions to be pure. But what if he had an ulterior motive? She even considered the worst-case scenario to be safe. Finally, she came to a conclusion.

If he does have an ulterior motive and stages a riot against the imperial family... None of us would be able to stop him.

Any resistance on her part would simply result in the loss of her sovereignty. Should any coup break out, the best way to mitigate the damage would be to console him and treat his fiefdom as an independent kingdom. This clearly meant one thing: she could no longer make an enemy out of him. It would be playing with fire.

Did I let the fire grow too large?

She wistfully thought out of nowhere. Just then, a surefire solution for her concern suddenly came to the queen’s mind.

Should I make him a member of the imperial family?

That appeared to be the more compelling option. Despite the fact that they were political partners on good terms, their relationship was something that could change at any time based on the opportunities that were present. It could be safer to completely tie him down through marriage.

Tsk...

When her thoughts reached that point, the queen clucked her tongue. She irately wondered how she ended up in her current predicament. Lloyd's chestnut-shaped head looked even more spiteful in her eyes, and she felt a pang of regret for not beating him up properly two days ago. But those thoughts and feelings of hers vanished as quickly as they appeared. She immediately erased the conflicted look that briefly appeared on her face and studied the chamber room with her signature gaze full of arrogance and intimidation.

"Very good," she announced. "As you can all see, being a wise man, Lloyd Frontera agreed to go through my test. Now, it is your turn to speak. Is there anyone who opposes the agreement I devised?"

As expected, no one spoke up. The nobles from both sides all bowed to show their respect. However, the expressions on their faces suggested otherwise. The supporters of the prophecy had a bitter look in their eyes and clicked their tongues in disappointment.

Haah... Her Majesty is siding with the opposition in the end.

To them, the test sounded more like a complete refusal to bestow Lloyd with the Tears of Summer. They believed the agreement was only a formality. A proclamation to disregard the prophecy. Their interpretation of the situation wasn't unreasonable.

A trade route across the Pantara Range? I know Lloyd Frontera is exceptionally skilled and has an impressive record of achievements... But this is an impossible construction to begin with.

A number of former kings had attempted to open a trade route in the aforementioned range. There were nine attempts in total, and they all failed. This would be the tenth failure. Lloyd would be unable to obtain the Tears of Summer. It was never going to happen. The proponents saw this as a simple fact, and the same thought lingered in the minds of the opposing faction.

Fantastic. Her Majesty has sided with us!

Inwardly, the opposing nobles rejoiced. The condition that Lloyd would only receive the Tears of Summer if he completed such an impossible construction was the same as refusing to give the divine item to him. They all nodded, satisfied and happy.

Her Majesty is truly wise. Of course, that's how it should be. We cannot give away a divine item of the imperial family to a lowly retainer, even if it's to follow a prophecy delivered by an angel. That cannot be done, even if it's just for the sake of protecting the dignity of the imperial family. It is unacceptable, even if not doing so goes against a prophecy from Heaven.

They did, however, entertain the possibility of Lloyd accomplishing the impossible and successfully constructing a trade route. That would not be a bad outcome for them either.

Although it is unlikely.

Therefore, the opposing faction exchanged glances and quietly celebrated their victory, overjoyed that their side had won. Javier and Julian were whispering in one corner.

"Sir Asrahan," whispered Julian softly.

"Yes, Master Julian."

"About Her Majesty's declaration," he said. "That looks unfavorable to Lloyd on the facade. But that is not the case in reality, is it? Lloyd intentionally masterminded this whole situation, hasn't he?"

“He likely did,” seconded Javier.

“Yes, that should be it. That’s the kind of person my brother is.”

“Yes,” seconded Javier once again. “He is sly, cheap, meticulous, and never does anything that will come at a loss for him.”

Julian looked at Javier for a second in a daze. “He sounds impressive somehow when you say it like that...”

“In what way?”

“Well, in many ways.”

Javier was slightly taken aback that he was feeling the same way. “I agree...”

None of them knew whether that was a compliment or an insult directed at Lloyd. At the same time, one question appeared simultaneously.

I wonder what goes through that man’s mind.

It remained a mystery to them. How cunning and calculated did one have to be to be able to pull this scheme off? But there was one thing they were both certain of. The queen, who expertly reacted and danced to Lloyd’s cunning tune at every chance without fail, was equally extraordinary. In terms of business, those two were none other than soulmates. And accordingly, Queen Alicia and Lloyd were staring at each other with a mysterious smile amidst the mixture of emotions from the nobles around them. Their smiles seemed to say, “It’s a deal!”

♣

The following morning rolled around. Lloyd, who had appeared at the chamber room the previous day, immediately left the capital.

Now that things have gone well with the queen, it’s time for me to get back to work!

This went without saying for Lloyd. There was no time to take a break. Since he successfully completed his negotiation with the queen, it was time for him to put in some hard work and obtain results.

That thought makes me happy and sad at the same time...

Lloyd let out a heavy sigh. He wished he could take a break and relax like the rich and lazy bum he fantasized dreamed of being. Would his dream of becoming a wealthy bum with a secure lifestyle ever come true? Lloyd was suddenly overcome with a sense of doubt that made his shoulders sag.

I want to rest. I want to play. I want to laze around, playing video games and watching TV in the corner of my room, giggling and chuckling over nothing with a bucket of fried chicken.

Lloyd couldn't recall the last time he did any of those activities. Those resentful thoughts of his, however, were fleeting. He slapped his cheeks to wake himself up, then confirmed Draggy was currently flying in the right path, and finally raised his head.

Whoosh! A gust of cold wind stung his cheeks. Between the thick strands of hair blowing in front of his eyes, he could see the Pantara Range spread out below him.

"Haah..."

Lloyd realized once more how rough the terrain of the range was. It looked like there were knife or ax blades randomly planted everywhere in the ground. Alternatively, the land seemed to have hundreds of potato chips embedded across it. The steep and clean-cut cliffs seemed to go on forever. That was Lloyd's initial thoughts after seeing the Pantara Range.

Not only are the slopes steep, there are several parts of the land covered in ice and permafrost.

It looked so slippery that the best climbers in the world or even spider men would double-check their life insurance before stepping foot on it. That was how dangerous the range was.

Tsk. I’m a madman, too, for volunteering to make a railroad across this place.

It was so ridiculous that even Lloyd let out a chuckle at the thought himself. The feeling must have been mutual as Javier curiously threw him a question, “Master Lloyd, are you sure you can... build a railroad here?”

“Seems impossible, right?”

“Yes,” Javier said, nodding. “I’ve become familiar with your design for trains and railroads after helping you with the construction in Hell. But how you could install a railroad on a terrain like this with such deep slopes is beyond me. Even if you do, I doubt the train will be able to properly travel upward.”

“You’re right,” Lloyd agreed with a nod. It was an excellent and accurate point. It would be impossible for any train to move upward on these cliffs, even with an amazing railroad that featured loops and switchbacks. It was completely impossible. That was an undeniable fact. Lloyd understood this better than anyone else.

Of course, it won’t run. Trains run on metal rails. But if they’re slippery and sloped, accidents are bound to happen.

And that was why South Korean companies designated the maximum slope of a railroad to 35‰.

The elevation difference was limited to under 114 feet for every kilometer along a railroad. If it surpassed that, the train would have a risk of slipping.

The maximum permissible difference in elevation per kilometer was 114 feet. Anything beyond that would jeopardize the operation of a railroad. But in this case...

Looks like it’s 114 feet for every 30 feet distance, and that’s for areas with tolerably steep slopes.

The trains literally needed wings to run. Despite the obvious challenge at hand, Lloyd was unconcerned.

“I wouldn’t have suggested the offer to the queen if the job was impossible,” replied Lloyd.

“Does that mean you have a way?”

“Of course.”

“What is that?”

“Are you curious?”

“I am.” Javier gave a nod. He was genuinely interested. He was curious about the extraordinary methods and skills his young master would employ to overcome the challenges this horrifying terrain presented.

Lloyd gave a brazen smile. “I am going to break it down to pieces.”

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Chapter 342: A Path Through a Mountain Range (2)

“I am going to break down the range into pieces.” Lloyd’s casual response came with a puckish smile.

Javier closed his mouth. He gave Lloyd a long look before speaking. “Did you... take any sort of substance this morning...?”

“No, I am fine,” dismissed Lloyd.

“You did not suffer from a head injury?” asked Javier again.

Lloyd frowned. “I said I’m fine.”

“Serious stress?” postulated Javier once again.

“I’m fine,” insisted Lloyd.

“Or are you going through a midlife crisis?”

“Hey, I’ve got many years before that hits me.”

“If not, have you started to lose clumps of hair by chance?”

“Hey.” Lloyd stared hard at Javier.

“Yes?”

“I’m telling you. I’m fine.”

“...”

“Trust me.”

“Okay, I will trust you.”

“Really?”

“Yes,” Javier replied, his voice cynical and distant. “I should believe you since you are very confident. Yes, you did not consume any drugs in the morning, been in a car accident, been under a lot of stress, experienced a midlife crisis, or hair loss.”

“Not that...” Lloyd sighed. “Can’t you trust the very first thing I said?”

“Are you referring to the demolition of the mountain range?”

“Yeah.”

“I believe you.”

“Really?”

“I do.” Javier indicated with a nod. He meant it. “You have always been this way. You propose an outrageous plan, and it works out in real life every time. That’s why I am going to trust you now as well.”

“Because I seem nuts?”

“Yes, because you seem like a madman,” deadpanned Javier.

“A madman...?”

“It is a compliment,” defied Javier.

“A compliment? That was a compliment?”

“It was,” explained the knight. “That’s the measure I use to determine whether I can trust you or not.”

“Tsk...” Lloyd licked his bitter lips. It appeared he had failed to properly teach Javier. “I’m starting to feel that the more I act out, the more you trust me.”

“You told me the same thing before,” pointed out Javier. “That the more you act like a madman, the more I should trust you. And that is why I am

doing this. You've never looked crazier than when you declared to destroy the range just a moment ago."

"Aha," remarked Lloyd. "That must mean you suddenly felt a strong urge to trust me."

"Of course."

Lloyd came to a decision. He had done a miserable job at providing guidance to Javier and had no clue what kind of impression the knight even had of him. The problem was that it was too late to change Javier's opinion of him now. "Well, I'm not saying that I'm going to demolish the whole range," Lloyd spoke, a bitter smile forming at the corners of his mouth. "After all, as you mentioned, the range is very steep. It's basically a giant cliff. So, I will shave down only a portion of it. Just a smidgeon."

"Enough to install a railway?" asked Javier dubiously.

"Correct," affirmed Lloyd. "If we recklessly shave down too much, the foundation could become unstable, so just enough for us to get the job done."

It was true. Lloyd's plan did not include demolishing the range or removing the peak because it would require too much labor, money, and time. Furthermore, destroying the entire mountain range would only benefit other people, not him.

The trade route should remain under the control of the Magentano House as long as it's operational. So a wide open road that's accessible to everyone would be less advantageous for the imperial family."

And Queen Magentano wouldn't want that to happen.

Of course, this is why I considered alternative methods. Such as boring a tunnel beneath the range, installing cable cars, or constructing a cog railway along the slopes.

But each of these options was problematic. For starters, the first option of the underground tunnel would be an extremely challenging project.

To do so, I'll have to investigate the entire foundation under the range. That will take a very long time to do. And what about the building? Even with Bangul, it will take several years before I can safely build a tunnel that stretches thousands of feet long.

The outcome of such a large construction wouldn't be worth the time, cost, and effort required for it. The project was not cost-effective, to put it simply.

And the main problem with a cable railway is with its safety.

Cable railways or cars used the same mechanism that was involved with pulling a bucket of water from a well. They worked by having a train car be pulled upward or downward with the help of a cable.

Yes, it's a simple system. And I wouldn't have to spend as much time polishing the terrain of the range. That's a clear advantage of the cable railway. However, it's also extremely dangerous and high maintenance. A single snag in the railway's cable would cause a disaster.

Lloyd's shoulders clenched in fear as he imagined the cable cars crashing to the ground as the cable holding them up snapped in half.

And the cog railway? It is impossible.

The technique was frequently used to build roller coasters in amusement parks.

The cogs tick and clack as the roller coaster slowly rises. The cogwheels underneath the roller coasters fit the other cogwheels planted in the center of the track and get pulled upward.

In some ways, it was the ideal railway for this kind of mountain range. The problems caused by the steep slopes of the terrain would be adequately mitigated by it, and the only drawbacks were the horrendous vibrations and

noise it created. But neither of these two issues mattered since the road was going to be used for transportation of cargo. However, there was one major reason Lloyd did not choose this technique.

I’m not that familiar with it.

Lloyd exhaled a sigh. He was a civil engineer who had no knowledge of mechanical engineering. What cogs were used in this kind of railway, what their standard measurements were, and the principles behind pulling a car against a steep slope... Lloyd couldn’t answer any of these questions.

For that tragic reason... The cog railway is not a possibility.

That eventually left him with only one viable option, which was to destroy a section of the range. The conditions of the range were favorable enough for it, much to his relief.

I have Draggy.

Its massive physique. Its power and endurance, which far exceeded that of an ordinary dragon. On top of that, its complete devotion to Lloyd. Draggy was a perfect excavator in every sense of the word.

So! It’s time to buckle up and get my hands dirty!

Lloyd clenched his fists. There is no time for a break. Though he felt a wave of sadness and resentment for a brief moment, he jumped and got to work after pushing his thoughts away. His first task was obviously surveying.

It'll be best to check over the terrain with my own eyes rather than depend on old documents. Survey!

[Scanning will begin.]

Bzzt!

Lloyd scanned the vast expanse of land beneath Draggy’s back. There was no need to survey the entire range.

Just about 30 miles from this spot.

Lloyd sharply surveyed the Pantara Range after activating his skill. The area he surveyed had a slight tilt toward the southeast from its center.

This is the best place for a trade route. It's also close to the original passageway in the east.

There wasn't a path across the mountains, but an older route that went around the eastern range did exist. Accordingly, Lloyd was surveying an area close to this original pathway.

That's what will allow me to build the new railway near the original pathway.

The thing was any new construction ought to be close to the existing facilities. Period. That was the unchanging truth. This was the case for South Korea, for instance.

People there were willing to go to great lengths to buy a home less than three minutes away from key infrastructure such as train stations, forests, schools, and supermarkets.

Why? This ensured rising house prices and a more comfortable lifestyle. The same principle could be applied here.

Obviously. It'll be troublesome and less efficient if the new trade route sits far from the existing pathway.

Moreover, building a trade route in this part of the mountain offered two advantages.

First advantage. It sits right in the middle of Magenta, the kingdom's capital city, and Namaran, the trade city of the northeast. This means that both cities will enjoy the benefits of the trade route. Port Cremo in the northeast will also indirectly benefit from it.

The second advantage?

This part of the range looks like it'll be the easiest to work with.

This was actually the biggest factor of consideration for him. Lloyd's eyes quickly raked over around three or four peaks in the range.

They look extremely narrow at a glance, but they actually aren't. It's only their peak that's narrow. The rest of the land is quite leveled. In fact, the width of a mountain range is wider than other types of terrains.

The Pantara Range was a hellish landscape with high, elongated, and narrow features. It was disgustingly tall and long in comparison to its sickeningly narrow width, and these characteristics gave it the appearance of a slew of window screens. However, the section Lloyd was looking at right now was slightly wider than the rest.

Similar in height. Broader in width. That's suggestive of a gentle slope.

However, it wasn't positioned perfectly enough for him to build a railway on it right away.

But who cares. This is the best spot no matter how I see it.

Lloyd found a cave to nestle in after two days of meticulous surveying and analyzed the gathered data in detail while grilling wild boar over the bonfire and chomping on it with Javier. He then went on to design it.

Let's see. What should I demolish before setting down the road?

Pondering intensely, Lloyd thought about a similar construction project on earth, the Darjeeling Himalayan Railroad.

It pretty much had the same conditions as this project. The railroad from Darjeeling to New Jalpaiguri was... What... 54 miles? I think? And the maximum elevation difference was 7,414 feet.

As a consequence, the elevation difference over the 54-mile journey was 7,414 feet. Even in today's modern world, that was outrageous. Lloyd's heart swelled with hope as he realized this magnificent structure was completed in 1881.

If those tea-loving people managed to pull it off, there's no reason I can't. Plus, they only took 26 months to complete the construction. So, I can definitely do it too. Of course, the terrain is rougher here, but I have Draggy and the fantastical creatures. The Skeleton Corps is also there for me. Javier, too.

Everything was in order. All he had to do was trust them and move forward. Lloyd continued developing his idea to destroy the range. His plan proceeded smoothly, and its execution was a breeze. This was all due to his Construction Guideline ability.

Ding dong.

[Design Skill Option ④: Construction Guideline has been activated.]

[Construction Guideline - The blueprint you have designed is marked in the actual terrain in the form of the guideline. This guideline will be visible not only to the designer but also to the workers on the site, and the workers will learn in real-time whether they are faithfully adhering to the blueprint (The Construction Guideline is synced to ② Floor Plan Marking (2D.).]

After opening the design data, Lloyd applied the data he obtained from running multiple simulations to real action.

Crackle...!

Lloyd felt his mana dip slightly as glowing blue lines drew around the range. These were the marks created by the Construction Guideline.

There. The rift between the peaks that look like ice cream cones and beer bottles.

Crackle!

Lloyd drew a line parallel to the rift between the two towering peaks. Following that, various engravings appeared on the gentle slope. Lloyd implemented his plan for the range with his design skill after some big and

small cuts and fillings, as he considered the strength, direction, composition, and overall balance. It was then Draggy's turn to work.

"Draggy, you know what to do, right?"

Clack!

"Hey! You do? You sure of it?"

Crack!

Draggy nodded its giant head, gesturing with his hands and feet.

Claack! Craack! Crack!

"Hmm... Yes. Dig, carve, and fill in the rift along the glowing bluish lines. You're right. And?"

Creak! Craaack! Snap!

"Don't throw away rocks and soil in random places while you dig and put them aside in their designated spot... Good. I believe there are still a few more precautions?" asked Lloyd as if there were more."

Crack! Clack! Creak!

"Good. Fold up your wings when you're moving around. Don't abruptly rock your tail or swing it around when you pivot. There you go. That's it. You remembered everything."

Clack! Crack!"

Draggy hula-danced in delight after receiving its long-awaited compliment. Lloyd was satisfied. He looked at Javier and said nonchalantly, "Now, I need you to hold down the fort here."

"Come again?" Javier retorted in annoyed shock.

“You need to hold down the fort here,” repeated Lloyd with equal nonchalance.

“Young Master...? What do you mean?” Javier cocked his head to the side.

Lloyd gave a brazen smile. “I need to visit a few places. So, you’ll have to supervise the construction site while Draggy takes down the mountain range.”

“

“Me? Supervise the site?”

“Yeah. It’s nothing difficult. You can use the construction guidelines. All you need to do is dig, carve, and fill in the area that has been outlined.”

Javier was speechless.

“Just make sure Draggy follows the guide,” added Lloyd, “If some areas aren’t properly carved down or filled in, tell him to do it again or do a bit of shoveling yourself. Got it?”

“I see...” replied Javier hesitantly. “But where are you going, Young Master?”

“Me? The capital, Namaran, and Cremo.?

“What business do you have there?”

“What else?” Lloyd’s shameless grin widened. It was as if he was going to meet up with a friend to retrieve what he had lent him or to a bank to withdraw money. “I’m going to empty the royal treasury,” he said with a shameless smile and expression.

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Chapter 343: A Path Through a Mountain Range (3)

Construction sites were not merely places for digging and erecting things from the ground. With all the materials, laborers, and miscellaneous costs involved, they also set the perfect stage for extravagant spending. There was money quietly, no, outright being poured into them, and that was typical everywhere around the world.

This has always been true throughout history. There have been hundreds of countries, dynasties, kings, and nobles that became obsessed over a massive construction project. There have been more than a few times when that obsession caused financial ruin for those who didn't consider the impact it would have on their wallet.

Construction sites weren't something to be overlooked. This was especially true the larger they were.

"And we're boring a tunnel into the range. And who commissioned the job to us?" asked Lloyd rhetorically.

"Her Majesty gave you the order as a form of test," replied Javier coolly.

"Right," affirmed Lloyd. "Then, who should pay for the construction?"

"Well, of course—"

"You are right!" Lloyd clapped loudly. "She should pay. Why should I use my own money? And that's why-"

"You are draining the royal treasury," Javier interrupted.

Lloyd put on a scowl. "Hey, drain the treasury? You are being dramatic."

Javier stared at Lloyd, narrowing his eyes.

"All I am doing is billing someone who commissioned a construction project so that I can purchase the required materials for it."

Lloyd spoke in a direct tone as if his response was common sense. Yes, the House of Magentano commissioned this construction project, and he was the contracted developer.

To sum up, I'm the developer. The queen's the property owner. Moreover, she's the richest property owner across the entire continent. There's no need for a credit construction.

Credit construction was when a developer covered a portion of the costs for a construction project since not every property owner in the world had an overflowing budget to work with.

The truth is that most property owners are slightly short on money, and that's why some developers offer loans in exchange for signing a contract with them.

This made it easier to start and complete construction projects. The property owners would gather funds while a construction was in progress to pay off their remaining balance. That was the general idea of a credit construction. However, now...

There's no need for that! Why should I when she has plenty of money to burn?

With no exaggeration, there was no need for him to spend a penny. Moreover, he didn't want to for another reason.

"I have to freeze time."

He had to freeze the flow of time for this project, too, since it was expected to take a few months.

The Darjeeling Himalayan Railway took 26 months to complete. Though this railway won't take as much time, I expect it to take at least a year.

Lloyd tallied up the months. It appeared that a year was sufficient. "So, I need everything from materials to people before I freeze time since there would be no way to get them elsewhere once time freezes."

“Well, you have a point. So, your plan is to receive everything at once?”

“That’s right. Everything. All at once. I’ll be back. Meanwhile, watch over Draggy, okay?” Lloyd asked, thinking that he had no time to waste.

“You speak as if... you’re leaving me to watch your dog.”

“Well, somewhat?”

“Don’t you have any other assurances for me?”

“Assurances?” asked Lloyd with a baffled look.

Javier nodded. “Yes.”

“What assurances?” Lloyd cocked his chin. “Wait, you can’t be asking me for sweet words of assurance like, ‘be safe’, ‘don’t skip meals’, or ‘watch out for the flu’?”

“Of course not, sir. However...” Javier shook his head, replying in his cold voice. “In case you experience an unintended event.”

“Me? An unintended event?”

“Yes, like an unfortunate accident, a beheading from the queen after upsetting her, or dying from chronic pneumonia on your flight back home... Those kinds of events.”

“...”

“So,” Javier went on. “If your absence prolongs, what should I do after supervising Draggy?”

“Are you planning to cheer or something?”

“Is that what you want me to do?”

“No. Not at all. Never.” Lloyd chuckled. He knew Javier was joking as usual, but it didn’t sound like that to him.

Really, my death might be something worth celebrating. The restoration of destiny won't happen if I'm gone, after all.

Lloyd was certain of it, even though no one knew that Javier's role as the main character had been stolen by him. He laughed at the thought. "Don't say such scary words, and don't get any strange ideas either."

"Ideas?"

"Never mind, dude. "I'll be right back." Lloyd hopped on Ggoming and departed for the capital after a light tap on Javier's shoulders. Fortunately, he didn't have to meet Queen Magentano in person because she had already arranged a special budget for him.

I expected no less of the queen!

Come to think of it, she was always like this. Always a step ahead of him.

On top of that, the budget is extremely generous.

Lloyd nearly burst into tears when he saw the amount written on the check from the imperial house. It was more than enough for the construction. Because of the generous financial support, the construction gained momentum as Lloyd traveled to Namaran and Cremo, respectively. Everything went swimmingly during his visits to both places as well. When word got out that Lloyd, the city's savior, was looking for various supplies, including groceries, construction materials, and other necessities, all the merchants competed to help him. They lined up in front of him and offered to give him a special lower price. It was as if they were competing in a survival show, and Lloyd was the judge. After going through a buffet-style selection of his supplies, Lloyd completed his preparation in ten days and headed back to the range. The place changed dramatically in ten days. No, it had completely transformed.

"Haah..."

Lloyd exhaled in awe as he took in the sight around him. First, the cone-shaped and cylinder-shaped peaks around the rift that Lloyd planned to

construct on were no longer there. More specifically, they had been cleanly broken down from the base, and the rift between them had also significantly changed. It was wider and easier on the eyes, with little change in altitude. Everything was going exactly as he had planned.

I know I ordered this myself, but it's impressive. Very impressive.

He felt a sense of accomplishment well up inside him. It was the exact outcome he had hoped for after experimenting with his simulation countless times.

Perfect.

This was good enough. He met all the minimum requirements to attempt the construction. However, there was one more thing he needed.

Everything has to be in place before I freeze the flow of time.

There was still a lot of work he needed to complete. Lloyd looked for Javier.

"Hey, are you sleeping?" Lloyd discovered Javier resting in front of a fire in his cave. Javier extended a plate with freshly grilled mushrooms toward him.

"Warm yourself first, Young Master," invited Javier. "I started grilling them earlier as I expected you to arrive soon."

"Are you sure I didn't catch you about to eat them all by yourself?"

"Looks like I have been caught," Javier said, playing along.

"I knew it. These aren't poisonous, by the way, right?"

"They are."

"For real?"

"No."

“Tsk.” Lloyd took the plate and ate it after carefully inspecting it. The warm and aromatic mushroom melted in his mouth. “Hey, do you have any more food you’ve squirreled away for yourself?” he asked, enjoying the remaining warmth in his mouth.

“No, Master Lloyd.”

“Good. Then, go and observe the area across the range.”

Javier sighed and looked hard at Lloyd in silence.

“Why? What? Why are you narrowing your eyes and glaring at me like that?”

“I was wondering if you are punishing me for not stashing away more food for you.”

“This isn’t a punishment.” Lloyd grinned as he chewed the mushroom. “I’m planning to fly around with Draggy in just a moment.”

“Fly around?”

“To Namaran and Cremo. I need to bring back the prepared supplies.”

“Oh.”

“That’s the reason. The whole range is going to be in an uproar while I fly around with Draggy.”

“Indeed. That should be the case. In fact, the place has been quite chaotic since a few days ago.”

“It was, right?”

“Yes. Ever since Sir Draggy demolished the two peaks of the range.”

“No surprise there.” Lloyd’s grin grew wider. It was only natural. After all, this was a massive undertaking. The two peaks had to be removed in order to widen the rift and smoothen the steep slopes. This was no ordinary

foundation manicure. The terrain had been pretty much ripped apart and put back together.

“The construction affected the areas beyond the range as well, after all.” Since the railway would run in two directions, a number of places in the range had to be smoothed and flattened. “That likely caused a commotion in the kingdom across as the range was once impassable to anyone, merchants or military alike, and served as a natural blockade for them against the Magentano Kingdom.”

And boom! As if it were a sculptor, the Bone Dragon randomly appeared and began to destroy the mountains, breaking down, carving out, and filling in the rough terrains. In the eyes of those on the other side of the range, that would have looked like a disastrous, terrifying invasion.

“The military should be rushing here now since the Bone Dragon appeared out of nowhere and started destroying the area that they deemed to be secure. Well, that’s a good thing for us anyway,” explained Lloyd in a calm voice.

“Good for us?”

“The range belongs to nobody under international law. It’s an unexplored area that can be developed without anyone’s permission as long as they have the skills and capital.”

“So, you are saying that everything is fine as we are developing the land within those parameters.”

“Yeah. And it’s not like we’re harming them.”

“But they must be petrified.”

“That is why I need you to be watching out on the other side.” Lloyd pricked the last mushroom piece. “The patrollers should be approaching to assess the situation. Or the military may arrive. That’s a problem. We don’t want them to figure out what we’re up to because this site is ours.”

“Why?”

“Simple. According to international law, the first to develop becomes the owner. So, we can well expect that they’ll put up a fight once they realize we’re doing this to build the trade route because it will eventually belong to the Magentano Kingdom, and they won’t be happy for the direct route to open up. So I need you to put a stop to it.”

“Stop them from coming up here?”

“Yeah. That way they won’t notice what’s going on here. However, don’t hit or kill them until I come back with Draggy. Can you do it?”

“Yes. It is doable.”

“Good.” It was done. Javier could do it. He could shoo away dozens of patrollers so simply and easily. It would be the case even if they barged in with hundreds and thousands of armies.

Anyway, this guy is just something.

Lloyd felt strange all of a sudden. He couldn’t believe that a man like Javier was following him. How? Why? This moment, following his instructions, sharing jokes, and sitting around the bonfire with him, suddenly seemed bizarre to Lloyd.

The Knight of Blood and Iron. When I read it, he was this fictional character I found cool and could only hope to hang out.

Lloyd stared hard at Javier sitting across from him. Javier, feeling the gaze, looked back strangely. “Master Lloyd? Why are you staring at me like that?”

“Oh, your brows are slightly asymmetrical.”

“My brows?”

“Yeah.”

“So...?”

“What do you mean, so? That shows you’re human too.”

“It makes me human that my eyebrows are not proportionate?”

“Yeah. It means that you are not perfect.”

“That means you are very human.”

“Hey.”

“If I look up close, it’s hard to find anything on your face that’s proportionate. Your eyebrows, eyes, and eyelids. Your nose bridge is a little wonky. Your nostrils are also different sizes. Crud. Disproportion is your face. And your personality. Whew. Let us not go there.”

“Ha... I hope millions of soldiers come marching here while I’m gone.”

“Do you wish for me to die, Young Master?”

“Yeah.”

A gutted look flashed across Javier’s face for a second.

“I’m joking. You know that, right?” Lloyd smiled like a naughty child, worried.

“Yes. I was joking too.”

“That my entire face is disproportionate?”

“No. That you are human.”

“...”

“That was the joke.”

“...”

Dammit. Lloyd cursed inwardly, thinking he would have punched Javier if he hadn’t been grandmaster. Lloyd then laughed, hoping that Javier would not die and that their story would not end with one of them dying or disappearing. He promised he’d make that happen. The night darkened as the brightly lit bonfire burned in front of them. At the same time, in the corner of the mountains, the Elemental King of the Pantara Range, who was slowly losing control over his territory, icily glared at the two of them.

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Chapter 344: The Elemental King’s Regret (1)

Elementals were created through the pure power of nature. Similar to ghosts, they were barely visible to the human eye, difficult to touch, and impossible to detect. Furthermore, they despised humans as their powers came from living in a pure environment of untouched nature. That meant they lost territory and power from the resulting damage of human contact and urban development. Just like what was happening now in the Pantara Range.

Pantalisa’s sad eyes darted to the shattered rock fragments. But they weren’t just shards of rock in his eyes. He recalled what they used to be.

“My love, it’s a shame. You had been beautiful and elegant for tens of thousands of years...”

Pantalisa remembered the day this range was raised up with the tectonic pressure from the ground, the way it soared through the sky, how it stood tall in the face of blizzards and gusts of wind for so many seasons. This piece of stone, once part of a boulder that protected one side of the range, was a quiet and dependable friend of his. However, now...

It had been obliterated. Hopelessly smashed to smithereens. The rock elemental that drew strength from it had vanished. Pantalisa had no way of knowing whether it had been extinguished or relocated. But one thing was certain. He had lost an old friend.

Step. Step. Pantalisa strode across the path, which was littered with tiny stone fragments and a plethora of marks and traces of human destruction. The tens of thousands of acres of permafrost, the snowflakes that walked over it, the high winds that carried the snowflakes, and the mossy shrubs that lovingly grew even as they trembled against it. The elementals inside everything had disappeared. He assumed they had been extinguished or fled. It made him sad to imagine them wailing over the loss of their homes and fleeing as they wiped their tears. That fact infuriated him.

His gaze advanced slowly toward a small cave on the range's flank, past the ruins of the peak. From inside, a bonfire light spilled out, reflecting two swaying human shadows. They belonged to the humans who had just arrived on the range and caused havoc.

"What am I supposed to do with them...?"

Pantalisa felt a strong desire to kill them right now. He wanted to rip their bodies apart using the wrath of nature. He couldn't, however, because he was a spiritual being with an amorphous body. It was physically impossible for him to touch humans. That unfortunate fact inflamed his rage even more.

The Pantara Range was one of the few places untouched by human presence... But now... Why?

His icy stare at the cave became even colder as he considered how to eliminate those humans and restore the land his friends had lost.

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Five days passed. Lloyd had visited the Frontera fiefdom alone with Draggy until now. But when he returned, he flew back together with the Skeleton Soldiers. The indomitable balls of energy who never complained about hunger or fatigue from sleep deprivation.

Looking at the proud 200 skeletons, Lloyd said, "Got it? You guys are frontrunners. My question is, for what?"

Turtle Neck, the leader of Skeleton Corps, raised its hands and stepped forward before scribbling something in the snow.

[We are the most handsome group of frontrunners!]

"Wrong..." Lloyd sighed. "I explained on the flight here. Anyone remember?"

This time, Square Jaw stepped forward.

[Construction of shower facilities for workers!]

“Great,” Lloyd chirped happily, “That was close. Anything else?”

[Accommodation! Cafeteria! Exercise facilities! Arcade room!]

“Exercise facilities are unnecessary. And an arcade room? You’ve gone too far. Anyway, you all are somewhat close. As frontrunners, you are in charge of building the camps for the laborers to sleep in.”

Lloyd took a look around at the rest of the Skeleton Corps. There were no better frontrunners for the construction of the worker’s facilities despite the harsh conditions here since they did not require food or rest.

The environment is harsh, and technically speaking, there’s no infrastructure here.

With the constant terror of blizzards and freezing temperatures in the area, they needed basic amenities and lodging facilities to stay for the entirety of the construction. This would be even more true after the flow of time was stopped.

I can’t send the workers outside this area since the rest of the world will be frozen. That means I’ll have to keep them here until the construction is finished.

Lloyd considered just proceeding with the construction at first but abandoned the plan after estimating that he would go beyond the one-year limit of the Time Freeze skill with only the skeletons’ help.

The Skeleton Corps aren’t enough. I need workers with more real-world experience. That is why there needs to be facilities for those individuals can stay in for a year.

Therefore, the Skeleton Corps first arrived to build the workers’ facilities.

“So,” said Lloyd to the Skeleton Corps, “Your work here will determine the life quality, safety, and happiness of the workers here.”

Clack!

Their heads bobbed in understanding.

“And make sure not to overwork yourselves,” Lloyd added. I know you all don’t eat or need breaks. However, it’s bitterly cold here. Remember what I told you on our flight? Frozen Shoulder. You respond this time. What precaution did I give you?”

[We need to warm ourselves around the bonfire every hour, so our bones will not freeze!]

“Good, you remember it well,” Lloyd said, making Frozen Shoulder smile. “Even if you can work indefinitely, the cold climate will make ice freeze between joints. It could cause you to trip and break your bones. So, keep my words in mind. Bonfire, every hour. Remember that.”

Creak!

“All right,” said Lloyd, “Let’s go over the blueprint of the lodging house you all will build.”

Lloyd lifted the scroll of paper that contained the design for the lodging facilities and opened it up for everyone to see.

***

The construction went swimmingly. It had to be due to its ever-so simple architecture.

“Got it? From here to there. The same as how it’s marked in the blueprint. Terraced all the way along the cliff slope.” Lloyd explained the concept behind the lodging facilities to Javier.

Staring at the blueprint, Javier asked, “Are you filling up the sides with logs?”

“Yeah, like a staircase.”

“Then, the ceiling of the lower floor would serve as the front garden of the upper floor.”

“Exactly,” replied Lloyd happily. “You are quick to understand.”

“Hence, my dislike,” said Javier under his breath.”

“For what?”

“I know what you are going to do from now on. You will be traveling around after delegating this job to me, abandoning me here at this site,” grumbled Javier.

“Come on, come on. Abandon you?” Lloyd spoke in a lighthearted tone. “This is a necessary process. So, make sure you’re doing a good job of supervising your skeleton pals. And one more thing. Did I explain to you how elves’ houses should be different?”

“Yes, you did,” said Javier with a resigned look on his face. “Don’t use any form of wood, including logs.”

Lloyd nodded. “So, dig out a few caves and carve some ice for doors.”

“Haah... I understand, Master Lloyd.”

Javier and Lloyd then went back to work. Javier buckled down and concentrated on constructing the lodging accommodations with the Skeleton Corps, all the while keeping an eye out for any suspicious movements beyond the range. Lloyd, on the other hand, traveled around the kingdom with Draggy, transporting the bundles of supplies he had previously purchased in Cremo and Namaran for the Pantara Range. It felt similar to shopping for a month’s worth of groceries. Following the transfer of goods, the workers would be moved next.

“Okay! Hop on! Quickly now!”

Every time Lloyd passed through the Frontera fiefdom, there was a raucous exclamation from the laborers on Draggy’s back. The first to set out for the range were 300 orc warriors.

Whoosh! When Draggy’s wings spread wide to lift everyone to great heights at great speed, the Frontera fiefdom shrank dramatically, and everything from the manor to the wetland, terraced field, apartment complexes, and eastern range diminished to the size of a toy as the entire landscape spanned beneath them. This enthralled the orc warriors.

“O-oink! We’re flying! We’re flying! Oink!”

“Mom! I’m a flying orc now! Oink!”

“Father! I’ve floated all the way up, oink!”

“Honey! I love you, oink!”

“A couple...! Oink!”

“A traitor! Throw him outside, oink!”

Following the strong and brawny orc warriors, the White Calvary lancers arrived, followed by the elf archers. Then there was the Engineering Corps. Corgidus and dwarf blacksmiths were the last to arrive.

Lloyd was taken aback by the dwarves. When he noticed a strange figure in the crowd, he led him to a corner and asked, “Mister Solitas? What exactly are you doing here?”

“I don’t feel comfortable...” Solitas’s face flushed with an emotion Lloyd couldn’t make out.

“Eh?”

“Did you know?” Solitas spoke in a shaky voice. “The existence of the guest slumbering in the guest’s chamber?”

“Guest’s chamber? Oh, you mean—”

“Yes! The Dragon King Verkis.” Solitas’s eyes burned with indignation. “Shouldn’t you have at least told me if he was here? Why didn’t you even give me a hint?”

“So, I guess you met him...”

“I did. I did get to meet him. I also didn’t recognize him. As a result, I... Haah. Forget about it.” Solitas sighed deeply. His failure to recognize Verkis cost him dearly. He was trapped in a lizard’s body for 24 hours, which was a humiliating, embarrassing, and terrifying experience.

I have never felt so powerless before. I couldn’t do anything.

Solitas tried to break the spell. But when that proved impossible, he was forced to admit that he would be trapped in that body for an entire day, which he spent hiding in between rocks in fear of being eaten by cats or caught by naughty kids eager to grill him.

I don’t want to tell him what I had to go through.

It hurt his pride to tell him the story. Solitas thus worked hard to appear unconcerned. “Anyway, being left at the fiefdom with such a strong presence is not comfortable. In addition, I have more to learn from my teacher.”

“Yes, I’m sure it is.” Lloyd nodded, understanding where Solitas was coming from wholeheartedly.

It’d be like an employee being forced to spend the day in the same room as their company’s CEO. It must be extremely taxing. Plus, I’m sure he’ll want to continue learning from Corgidus.

Since there would be no more sludge to burn as the world would freeze soon, Lloyd concluded that it’d be all right for Solitas to be here.

“Anyway, welcome. Unpack your stuff in your room first.”

Everyone arrived and was immediately assigned to their respective rooms. The food, materials, and supplies for them were fully prepared. Everything was set for the start of the construction.

Great. Once it’s past noon tomorrow, I’ll freeze the passage of time.

Lloyd thought as he observed the sky darkening between the light snowflakes. He then went to bed, knowing that all he had to do the next day was choose the right time to freeze time and begin construction.

The next morning, however, everyone at the site was greeted with a disastrous blizzard caused by the Elemental King throughout the range. The violent and cruel snowstorm arrived with biting cold, rendering construction to be impossible. As a result, excitement stirred amongst workers.

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Chapter 345: The Elemental King’s Regret (2)

“Here comes the snow... Snow... It’s falling from the sky... It’s coming down... In buckets... Dammit.”

Swooosh! A strong wind started to blow all over, and snowflakes came scattering everywhere. Each snowflake was the size of a baseball, and the wind from this blizzard appeared to be sharp enough to cut his skin. Lloyd blankly chuckled at the sight.

“Ahaha. Dammit.”

Now that all the supplies and laborers were in place, he planned to deliver a grand speech and stop the flow of time. He planned to start constructing the historic railway that would cross through the Pantara Range.

What rotten timing. Out of all days, there had to be a blizzard today.

Lloyd sighed, looking up at the sky, wondering if the blizzard couldn't have come at a worse time. But he couldn't see the sky because everything was foggy and gray from the swirling snowflakes.

Looks like construction won’t happen today.

Even with the Bone Dragon, a grandmaster, and a team of experienced workers, no construction could take place in this kind of climate. Humans couldn’t win against nature.

It’ll only harm me in the end if I waste energy by acting stubbornly.

Lloyd licked his lips in bemusement as he watched the storm. He suddenly remembered how much he despised monsoon season in South Korea.

I couldn’t earn money during those seasons.

Working paused on many construction fields when the monsoon season arrived and the weather turned bad. That meant he had fewer opportunities

for pay.

The thing about this line of work is that you seem to make a lot when you just look at your daily wage. In the long run, however, with all of your forced breaks and whatnot, the total sum is surprisingly low.

As a result, he detested monsoon season. He despised rain and snow. However, his sentiment was not shared by everyone at the site.

The old men who didn't have much greed for money, or the people who waited a few days for their last paycheck to run out before working again. Those men didn't like working too hard, and actually enjoyed having occasional downtime.

Lloyd's gaze crawled from the sky to the ground toward the campsite. Workers were cheering and shouting in joy in the front yard.

"Snow! Oink!"

"How fun! Oink!"

"So tasty! Oink!"

The Orc warriors were having as much fun as wild boars in the mountains. They even stripped half-naked and joyously had a snow fight while flexing their muscles.

"Heavy snow! Awesome! That's why! We have no work! Oink!"

"Blizzard! Cold! Rubbing it against my muscles! Helps with training! Oink!"

"Large snowflakes! Chilled to the core! Eating them makes my stomach tremble! Bulking up my intestines! Oink!"

Stop it, you nutjobs...

Lloyd sighed deeply, gradually beginning to understand the project owners' anxiety every time inclement weather halted construction in South Korea.

The construction period grows longer, proportionately wasting more time and money. Haah.

Lloyd, on the other hand, had no choice. The others had a different attitude from him. And so, he decided to accept the blizzard. Meanwhile, most of the workers were ecstatic, including the White Cavalry's members, who were known for their bravery and honor.

"It feels like we came here for vacation since we have no work to do with heavy snow and can just laze around in bed all day," a lancer said.

"Yeah," agreed the other. "It snowed just like this during the war in the Panos Plains."

"Oh, that had been very exciting. The number of frostbite patients there were."

"Yeah. Compared to that, this storm is nothing but a gentle breeze. Really, a breeze."

"You are right. I went out for some fresh air, and it was warm then."

"I know, right? I wish it'd stay like this. That way we can laze around meanwhile."

"That is exactly what I mean."

Given that the White Cavalry lancers had already endured all sorts of weather conditions in their battles, this blizzard did not weaken their resolve or military spirit. The elves reacted differently to the blizzard.

"Woww! What a fresh breeze of nature!"

"The grace of nature!"

"A pleasant gift!"

The elves had always preferred to go along with nature. They accepted whatever climate that nature provided. If the wind was hot and humid, that

was what it was. If it was cold, well. It was cold then. Here in this mountain range, their ability to adapt to any climate shone through.

The dwarves also adapted to the blizzard in their own unique way.

“Excuse me, Master Corgidus, are you not cold?”

“Are you?” retorted Corgidus.

“Eh? No, not at all. I can’t feel any sensation on my skin.”

“Right. Tell me, how long has it been since you have worked with me? 80 years?”

“Yes, Master.”

“That should be enough time to numb your skin,” observed Corgidus as he rubbed his cheek.

“Yes. It seems the prolonged exposure to the furnace killed my sense of touch.”

“Ahaha. Congratulations. You are now a true blacksmith.”

“It’s all thanks to your guidance.”

Just like that, the dwarves had been literally desensitized to the point that the severe blizzard had no effect on them. Instead, they welcomed the unexpected break. The human soldiers of the Engineering Corps were just like the rest of them.

“Yowza! This winter coat that just came in is super warm.”

“Isn’t it?”

“Yeah! It’s really something. Here, look. Look how densely stuffed the linings are. It’s been nicely padded.”

“I know, right? We should be thankful to Master Lloyd.”

“I couldn’t agree with you more. He bulk-ordered these warm clothes for us... I can’t help but be moved every time he takes care of us like this.”

“Yes, I agree. I can still remember what he said when he gave the coat to me.”

“What did the young master say?” The man’s eyes shone with expectation.

“‘Nothing better than a puffer in the winter!’ That’s what he said.”

“Oh, so the name of this jacket is ‘puffer’?”

“It appears to be.”

“Nothing better than puffers in the winter...”

“Hurray to the puffers...”

The soldiers were overjoyed as they wrapped themselves in the lavish liner jackets. Nobody noticed the blizzard, not even the orcs, elves, dwarves, or humans. It had no effect on them. Instead, they were simply ecstatic about the unexpected break.

This unexpected situation, on the other hand, bruised the ego of Elemental King Pantalisa to the core.

What are they...?

He couldn't get his mind around it. This blizzard had been his venomous retaliation, a serious, no-joke revenge to freeze them to death and eliminate the intruders because he couldn't physically touch them. He had used all of his strength to create this storm. But the end result was heartbreaking. It only made them happy.

Why doesn't this make anyone cold? Why aren't they writhing in agony? Why?! And why are they making snowmen all over?

Everyone laughed, oinked, and shrieked with delight as they built snowmen, fought, and played on the slides. Pantalisa shuddered in

annoyance and felt terrible self-hatred at the sight. He understood why this occurred.

I have become weak.

Too many footprints of external creatures had been marked into the range. The natural appearance had been lost too much. And that was how much he lost his power.

But... I can’t back down like this.

Pantalisa was not about to give up so easily. He summoned nature's wrath with more venomous resolve as everyone had the time of their lives in their camps. Everyone, on the other hand, was unconcerned about the worsening blizzard. They simply jumped for joy at the extended break. Lloyd was the only one whose happiness had plummeted to the lowest depths.

“Dammit... Something’s off about the weather. Something’s behind it for sure,” observed Lloyd with serious distaste.

The blizzard had been pounding the entire range for six days. Lloyd shuddered at the biting wind, suspicious of its strength. It appeared to be determined to freeze everyone and halt construction.

I thought it’d go away after two or three days. But I don’t see this ending any time soon.

The blizzard was worsening in degree. Waiting out like this would...

It’d be troublesome.

There were over a thousand workers present. Every day, tons of food and goods were consumed, and it was only a matter of time before snow piled up and froze the mountain.

The clean-up and the foundation job will take a hit. And there’ll be more chances of an avalanche. Safety issues are a big thing, too.

This whole turn of events couldn’t be any more frustrating. Everything was all set for the construction. But it hadn’t been able to begin at all.

“There’s certainly a problem here. I’ll have to solve it,” resolved Lloyd.

“But how will you stop a blizzard?” asked Javier innocently.

Lloyd crinkled his nose. “I don’t know. But you see, don’t you think this blizzard is a bit strange?”

“Strange?”

“The mana. Can’t you feel it?”

“Do you mean the subtle hint of mana in the air?”

“Yeah.” Lloyd gave a nod. The biting wind did contain a trace amount of mana. It was very small, like a few spices. It was certainly undetectable to those who couldn't use the Asrahan Core Technique. “But I can sense it. Just a little bit. What do you make of that?”

“There must be an elemental in the wind.”

“Yes, indeed.”

“And that is a problem, how?” said Javier. “It is common for elementals to be seeped into nature, be it the wind or creek water.”

“Of course, it’s nothing special. Under normal circumstances.”

“But are you saying that is not the case now?”

“Of course.” Lloyd nodded. “This blizzard. I can feel the presence of the elemental that has been interfering with my construction for the past six days.”

“...”

“Who cares if it’s an elemental or whatever? They’re disrupting my work, and I can’t leave them be. I’m suffering a great loss here.”

“But, Master Lloyd, you are talking about an elemental,” reminded Javier.

“Okay, so?”

“It will not be as easy as you think to resist against them.”

“Well, you are right.” Lloyd immediately understood what Javier was saying. Since the elemental was a spiritual entity like a ghost, it couldn't be touched, hit, or grasped.

“As such, I am curious. As far as my common sense goes, humans and elementals cannot touch each other, except for the Elemental King who looks like a wild ginseng.”

“Yeah, that’s common sense. The exceptions would be, if there are any, magic spells of great magicians and auras of swordmasters.”

“However,” Javier immediately countered, “Even the magics and auras barely do any damage, even if they exert all of their strength.”

“Yeah, I know that. That’s common sense. It’s a known fact that it’s impossible to physically beat up the elemental king.”

“Yes, I am also aware of that. So, how are you going to-”

“How am I going to beat up this blizzard-causing elemental?”

“Yes.” Javier was genuinely intrigued. At the same time, he suspected Lloyd was wrong this time. He reasoned that it was better to wait for the blizzard to pass because that was the way of nature.

Lloyd gave a sly, mocking grin a split second later. “I have plans. So, let me ask you a question. Do you, by any chance, like shaved ice?”

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Chapter 346: A Crafty Bait (1)

“So, do you like shaved ice?”

“Young Master?” retorted Javier. His gaze seemed to ask what Lloyd was saying.

Lloyd smiled at his reaction, and he thought...

What am I saying? I mean, let’s crush that bastard elemental who’s been keeping us from construction for several days now.

Something had to be done. He would die before the blizzard stopped if he just sat back and let the elemental do whatever he pleased.

The course of nature? Wait until it calms down? Not a chance.

Lloyd might have had the option to wait if he was in any other situation. But not right now, when his construction project had been delayed before it even started. “It’s probably the elemental residing in the Pantara Range, right?” he inquired, determined. “And I’m sure his specialty is the element of ice and snow. That’s why he’s so attached to this place.”

“You are likely correct,” replied Javier. “That is, if he is causing this blizzard as you assume.”

“He’s probably the one behind it. That’s why I’m thinking about taking advantage of his attachment.”

“Use his... attachment?” asked Javier.

“Yeah.” Lloyd gave a nod. His smile gave off the impression that he was already somewhat convinced his plan would work. “I’m sure you’re aware of how sensitive elementals are to environmental harm. Everyone knows this.”

“I do,” said Javier. “I heard it was a shared trait among elementals.”

Lloyd gave a contemplative nod. “And what do you think is the case for the elementals living in this remote range?”

“They are... probably more sensitive than elementals living in other places.”

“Yes. They haven’t had much interaction with humans while living in a remote area with hardly any human presence.” Lloyd spoke with well-founded confidence.

When it comes to things like this, elementals and humans are not all that different. To give an example, suppose John relocated from a house in a bustling market to a condo close to a train station. Would the sound of the train bother him? Hardly. He might think it is quieter or not all that different from a noisy market. But what if things go the other way? What would happen if John moved from a peaceful province or suburb to a boisterous condo in the middle of the city? At first, the outside ruckus would be terrifying and hard to get used to. John may even harbor a grudge against his noisy unit.

That would be the case for most people. As a result, in both cases, the elementals in nature would go through what John did.

It shouldn’t be much different between elementals and humans. The elementals who have been living in a mountain behind a human village will already be used to the entry of humans into their territory. They’d be similar to John moving to a city after living near a bustling market.

But as for the elementals in this Pantara Range which had almost no human traffic...

They would be similar to John moving from a remote area to a city. And so, this means the elementals here aren’t used to the presence of humans. They are responding far, far more sensitively than most elementals.

The ongoing blizzard from the past few days proved his point. Lloyd was certain.

“So they’ll be easy to provoke.” Lloyd spoke confidently, believing that this was a universal phenomenon for both humans and elementals.

Javier narrowed his eyes. “Hmm. I see what you mean. You will further destroy the environment to draw out the elemental.”

“Yeah.”

Javier gave him a look.

“What? Why? What? We’ve bulldozed two peaks already. The fate of the range has already been sealed. Besides, I’m barely even touching it compared to some of the other things I’ve demolished before. I just need to take down a little bit of the land nearby.”

“What a fantastic person you are.”

Lloyd shot a question at his knight. “What was that?”

“Nothing, Young Master.”

“Nothing? I heard what you said.”

“Oh, did you?” Javier asked with feigned remorse and guilt.

“Of course,” huffed Lloyd. “You insulted me out loud. How could I miss that?”

“Congratulations then,” said Javier.

Lloyd frowned. “Congratulations? For what?”

“It seems that you have no problem with your hearing yet.”

“Of course. Everything else is well with me, too.”

“I am sure it is.”

“Well, yeah. I am a swordmaster.”

“Yet, you have never dated a girl before.”

“Ouch...” That was a direct, potent blow to Lloyd's ego. It was like someone had flown supersonic and thrown a cone of hard metal directly into his body. Suppressing the wave of resentment, Lloyd asked, “Hey, it feels like your burns are becoming more sophisticated?”

“What is a ‘burn?’” asked Javier.

“Tsk, never mind. Let’s get moving. It’ll only make the elemental happier if we stay still like now.”

Since he had a general idea of the cause behind the current situation and what to do, it was time to get moving. Lloyd put on his leather armor and winter clothes. Then, he packed two servings of lunch and a few tools, including a large hammer, pickax, and foldable shovel.

“Okay, let’s go!” hurried Lloyd.

Trailing behind, Javier had to hold back a bitter laugh as his young master marched forward in inexplicable excitement as if they were going on a picnic. As he listened to Lloyd explain his plan, the knight’s doubts only grew stronger.

“I’m going to lure him in. That’s when you’ll beat him up,” instructed Lloyd.

“Young Master?”

“I said beat him up. Don’t you know what that means?”

“I do. That is why I am asking you again. Don’t you know that physical force from a human is practically useless against an elemental?”

“Yeah, and that’s what makes it better,” reasoned Lloyd.

“Better? Please elaborate?”

“That means we can beat him to a pulp without having to worry about killing him.”

Javier gaped in disbelief.

“So, I need you to put away your conscience while you trample him into the ground.”

Javier was at a loss for words.

“What? What are you glaring at me for this time?”

“Nothing, Master Lloyd. It is simply that beating up, no, attacking the elemental seems to be an insufficient plan,” said Javier as he relaxed his eyes.

“I assume you mean, since he will not die, what good is it to lay an attack when we cannot subdue him?”

“Yes. Is there any other plan you have in mind?”

“Yes, I have one.”

That was the end of the conversation, leaving Javier with no time to hear more as Lloyd froze in his tracks. Glancing around, Javier saw that they were standing between two precipitous cliffs on a broad, even stretch of land.

“All right,” said Lloyd. “This should do it. The area is far from the camp and so dingy that it looks like no human has set foot in here for at least a couple hundred years. Wow. It’s the perfect place to execute our plan. Javier.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

“Hide over there.” Lloyd gestured toward the cluster of three or four boulders stacked on one side. They would make a good hiding thanks to the shadow they cast.

Javier moved dutifully and stood there staring at Lloyd, half-curious, half-worried that the plan would succeed. He licked his lips a moment after that, seeing what Lloyd was scheming.

“Hey!”

Lloyd’s shout boomed across the land. Then, he lifted his shovel high, charged it with aura, and started to dig, fueled by the pent-up rage from the past few days.

“Did you like disturbing my construction, you bastards?”

Boom! Crash! Crash! Boom!

The oddly shaped boulders and rocks could date back hundreds of thousands of years. All completely untouched by human hands. These pricelessly valuable stones shattered into tiny fragments. But Lloyd had no regrets about what he was doing. If anything, he was enjoying himself.

“You see this?!” bawled Lloyd, “This is the power of construction that we primates possess!”

Crash! Boom! Boom!

Lloyd began shoveling in a more rhythmic manner. He continued and launched mana blasts everywhere, boring holes into the cliffs as the breathtaking scenery quickly fell apart. The range eagles flew away in shock, flapping their wings, and even then, he laughed. At the sight, Javier experienced a wave of shame as deep as a cup of espresso.

Mad bastard...

Javier questioned how he got into this situation. How did it begin? What sequence of events brought him to assist and serve such a young master? He was worried about the future of the world, as well as about his current situation and future.

While Javier was consumed by resentment, Lloyd started to carry out his destructive plan with greater efficiency. With his surveying skill, he

calculated how he could take down more of the cliff while avoiding collapsing it. Then, he used his shovel, hammer, and pickaxe based on the calculations he made. Ten minutes later. There finally came a reaction. The first sign of it came in the form of a strong snowfall.

Whoosh! It seemed the mountain range was upset with Lloyd for his unwelcome intrusion and the disturbance he caused as snow began to fall more heavily. A gust of snowy wind suddenly made everything around him hazy. It was a snowstorm.

“Yes, yes.”

It came. He was right as expected. Lloyd gave the bright smile of a store owner who had his first customer in three days. He was happy that his prediction was right.

I can just feel it. There’s a slight movement of mana in the blizzard. Only this time, it's more obvious compared to the movement of mana in the blizzard back at the construction site. This means...

The elemental was near. Lloyd turned around and glanced his eyes at Javier as soon as he realized it. *“Did you feel it?”*

“Yes.” Javier nodded, his eyes doing a quick scan of the place. It looked like he was trying to spot the elemental’s location using the Asrahan Core Technique.

“I’ll help you out.” Lloyd balled up his shovel, dashed over to a precipice, and rammed the shovel in. Then, he dragged his aura-charged shovel sideways and etched several deep lines into the cliff.

Like this! Like this! Scrabble!

He connected, bent, and laid down his lines into letters. And they read...

[Hello, elemental? I have a question for you. Why are you throwing your life away in this remote corner of the Pantara Range? I heard that other elementals nowadays have made a smooth transition into society and found

great career opportunities for themselves. Are you really fine with being the only one wasting away here?]

Clang! Clang! Clatter! Lloyd's shovel made a more cadenced movement. He continued etching more questions into the cliff wall.

[How much is your salary? Do you get a bonus? I heard your neighboring elementals have been promoted several times. Aren't you going to get a job? When are you going to get married? And isn't it about time to get a house?]

Thwaaack! Clatter!

[I care about you. That's why I'm say saying this, so don't be offended. Listen up. If you plan on getting married, you need to have at least two babies. The birth rate has gone down a lot lately. But if you stay buried down here, you won't be able to date or get married. When I was younger...]

Slash! Clash! Slash!

Without taking a moment to rest, Lloyd scribbled furiously, recording any thought or question that occurred to him. Whether the elemental understood anything or not did not matter to him. The content was not important. It was vandalism in and of itself that mattered.

My doodles on the cliff alone are going to make him angry!

Lloyd's hands became even busier. The result of his efforts came immediately.

Swooosh! The blizzard suddenly grew so intense that it almost tripped Lloyd by its force.

Ack!

The gusts of wind nearly knocked him off the cliff. But he caught himself and persevered as he drove the shovel into the ground. He then grinned.

I got you.

The Asrahan Core Technique allowed Lloyd to locate the elemental in the middle of the blizzard.

In that case, Javier should know exactly where he's positioned. Like now.

Glancing up into the snowdrift, Lloyd made out a vague shape with the opaque silhouette of a person or a swaying blanket.

I got you, elemental bastard.

Lloyd was quite certain that the elemental would be feeling comfy even though the latter's location was spotted. No sense of crisis or anything.

I'm pretty sure he's relaxed right now since he knows it's quite impossible for us to physically hurt him. Even a swordmaster's aura would be like a slight pat against him.

Lloyd speculated that the elemental had to know that humans would never be able to touch him. If not, there would be no explanation for the blizzard and the explicit presence.

And now, it's time for you to become shaved ice.

As soon as a vicious smile bloomed on Lloyd's face...

Boom! Javier, a grandmaster who had completely surpassed the level of a swordmaster, struck the back of the elemental's head with his almighty aura.

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Chapter 347: A Crafty Bait (2)

“Father! This is how you wield a club, right?”

Memories could sting sometimes. The older and more distant they were like a faded antique painting, the more effort it took to recollect them. And the pain in your heart would reflect the amount of effort you put in. It was a sharp, throbbing pain on one side of your chest that made you unconsciously let out a stifled sigh. In a state of daze, you would wake up from your sleep and realize the voice you heard a moment ago was a mere fragment of a memory inside your dream, not reality.

Count Frontera sighed. His gaze remained vacant and lifeless as he contemplated the voice he had just heard. It seemed too alive, too real. His eyes scanned his room, but he could not find his son.

It was a... dream.

He let out another sigh, fearing the lump in his throat would choke him otherwise. The count felt a developing urge to fall into an eternal slumber just so he could hear his son’s voice and lively shouts as a child in his dreams again.

Yes. That’s how he was then.

Count Frontera grinned bitterly as he remembered. Lloyd badly wanted to learn how to sword fight from his father as a child. He would beg him for a lesson every time he saw a stick, club, or anything resembling a sword with whatever he found in his hand. But Count Frontera was afraid that Lloyd would not develop a strong foundation for swordsmanship if he tried to teach him with his lacking skills. Rather, he vowed to himself that he would find a qualified teacher for his son in the future, even if that would cost him money. But he missed his timing to do so.

He lost interest after two years.

When he finally found a teacher, Lloyd became apathetic toward sword fighting. Count Frontera initially believed his son had lost interest in it. But he soon discovered the truth, long after the teacher had left.

It wasn't that Lloyd wanted to learn sword fighting. He just wanted to spend time with me.

Count Frontera felt a pang of guilt at the realization. But by that time, Lloyd had already gone astray. He was causing chaos and getting into trouble daily. The count didn't know whether puberty had just hit him hard or it was in the boy's nature.

"I'm sorry, my son..." He regretted not showing enough love to Lloyd then and not knowing that they didn't have much time left together. And now, he had become a failure of a father who could do nothing but sigh in regret as he was doing this morning. Just then...

Clack. Someone gently opened the door.

"Are you awake?"

It was his wife, Countess Frontera, who must have woken up before him and gone out for a short stroll. But her eyes were red. He smiled bitterly. "I suppose you feel the same as me."

"Yes..." The couple, thinking alike, silently sat on the edge of the bed. After staring at the wall for a while, Count Marbella said, "Our Lloyd... Where do you think he is?"

"I... I do not know." Another sigh. Count Frontera was curious. He wanted to know. "But I would like to believe that he is doing fine no matter what or where he is..."

"I feel the same. That is why I just came back from speaking with an angel."

The count quietly wrapped his arm around her shoulder. She leaned against him.

And in a soft tone, struggling hard to speak, she said, “I was curious. I felt suffocated as it was. So, I wanted to ask if Lloyd was doing well. You know, since an angel cannot lie.” She felt him tighten her hand. “But I could not dare say my question out loud. It seemed like I would be wronging the current Lloyd. I feel too indebted to that child to do so.”

“You made the right choice...” His voice cracked.

“I did, right?”

“Yes...” he said, lacking certainty.

This time, she wrapped his hand. “He will tell us when the time comes, right? The boy has a kind heart.”

“Yes... I believe he will.”

“I know it. He is a good kid.”

Her eyes grew red and teary again while his nose reddened. Clutching each other, the two decided to put their trust in Lloyd and wait for him to eventually tell the truth. They hoped for the best while trying to put on a smile.

He is a kind... dutiful... and hardworking kid...

***

I’m proud of you! My faithful knight! Hurray to Javier!

At the same hour, in the mountain range distant from the Frontera fiefdom, on the cliff spot, Lloyd gave a wide, contented smile. He couldn’t help it as he heard a clear, vivid clamor ring across the area.

Boom! The noise came from Javier’s aura, creating a crisp sound as it hit the Elemental King’s head.

“Ack..!”

Pantalasa, the Elemental King, was thrown to the ground in shock.

Wh-What in the world?

He was unable to wake up from his daze. His head was sore and throbbing. This was the first time he felt this kind of pain.

Did he just hit me? That silver-haired human?

He then jumped right back to his feet as soon he touched the ground.

No! That's impossible!

It really was impossible. That was the only rational conclusion. Ever since he was born into existence, this was what he believed to be the constant, undeniable, and unchanging truth. His belief had been proven to be correct several times in real life.

Humans can't physically touch me. Although I had fought against a swordmaster on three different occasions before now, their auras never hurt this much...

Panatalasa's mind flew back to the time he fought three other swordmasters on this very range.

The first swordmaster came about 1,200 years ago. He was a brawny warrior. I met the one after him about 980 years ago. The most recent incident was about 110 years ago. It was with a knight of a king who was trying to make a plank road over here.

Every single one of them was easily defeated with a simple method.

They all used their aura against me, but it never worked. I was basically untouchable, so their attacks didn't hurt me at all. Regardless of how hard they swung their swords, it just felt like I was being patted.

In short, a swordmaster's aura was completely ineffective against him.

I let them occasionally hit me with their auras while making them withstand harsh blizzards and breathe in unbearably cold air. It was a real success. No matter how strong the knights and warriors were, they eventually couldn't continue after their body temperature began to drop... So, why am I in so much pain right now?

A swordmaster's aura couldn't hurt him. As far as he knew, this was the highest level of skill a human could reach. As such, they didn't have the ability to physically hurt him, the Elemental King. That was the undeniable and unchanging truth of the matter.

Why?

Clang! Bam! Javier raised his aura-charged sword and began hitting both sides of Pantalasa's face in quick, multi-directional movements.

Ack! Ack!!

It hurt. It was so painful that it made him cry. This confused Patanlasa more.

What the heck? Is an aura... supposed to be this painful? Is he using dark magic or something?

But Pantalasa couldn't detect any dark energy coming from the human. That only threw him into greater confusion.

Who is this human?! Ouch! Arggh!

Just then, a thought crossed his mind. What if this man was a grandmaster, something he thought was only possible in theory?

Seriously? Really?

If that wasn't the case, his aura wouldn't be this painful. The attacks from this human were incomparable to what he had experienced before. *Thwack! Thwack!*

Ah!! Ouch!

The knight now began to attack his ribs and neck. It occurred to him that he might experience a sore neck for the first time since he came into existence. Every time the knight punched his ribs, his stomach tightly knotted up. He finally had a realization.

This knight is a grandmaster.

A sense of dismay and crisis. Countless emotions swirled inside him. However, the elemental did not easily give up. He remembered that the range needed his protection, even while enduring the most intense fight and pain in his life. Instead, his wrath grew stronger than ever.

How dare you?

Fwoosh! Pantalasa, enraged, began to conjure up sharp gusts of wind all around him. With that, freezing cold air swept the area while hailstones larger than a human's fist flew around in the air at 120 miles per hour.

To the human who dares to attack me, get a taste of nature's wrath!

Pantalasa was determined. He would freeze the knight solid and make an example out of him for anyone who dared to enter the range in the future.

I don't care if you're a grandmaster or not! There are no exceptions!

Fwoosh! The strong snowstorm was terrorizing. Its sweeping winds would make any form of life caught in the middle of it meet its demise. However, Javier was the exception.

Javier's eyes shone sharply, and he proceeded to his next step, which was dislocating Pantalasa's jaw.

Zip! Swoosh! Swish! He gently moved forward, taking two more steps before briefly pausing. At that moment, a fist-sized hail brushed past the tip of his nose at a speed of 168 miles per hour. He was able to detect, no, predict all the movements of the 471 pieces of hail from when they began to fly in his direction until they passed by him.

Clang! Clang! With a flash of his blade, countless fist-sized hailstones shattered into glittering fragments of ice that scattered across the air. Amidst it, Javier acted as if the violent blizzard heralding a temperature well below zero was a gentle spring breeze. He held his sword high, aiming for Pantalasa's head. *Thwack!*

Ouch!

Pantalasa teared up a little and felt a sense of abysmal doom.

How? How did he break through the blizzard?

Pantalasa was unable to understand what was happening. Even if he was a grandmaster, he shouldn’t have been able to neutralize the blast of snow he just summoned so easily. The chilly air alone was easily below freezing at -182 degrees Fahrenheit. Moreover, there were hundreds of hailstones flying in every direction at above 124 miles per hour within a few feet of each other. In other words, it should have been impossible to predict all of their movements.

His muscles should have frozen in the air as he was hit with deadly and unpredictable attacks from all directions. Even if his senses are above that of a swordmaster’s, he should not be able to properly fight. So, how? How did he do it?

Pantalasa felt wronged. He couldn’t process this whole situation. What he didn’t know was that the Asrahan Core Technique gave Javier the ability to track every movement of mana as if he were a high-performance radar. Furthermore, Panatalasa was unable to comprehend something else, such as how Javier managed to hit only his weak points.

Thwack! Thump! Thwack!

Ack! Eek! Ouch!

Crack! Thump! Thwack!

Ouch! Eek! Heek!

Every time Panatalsa floated away to dodge his attack, Javier came first and struck him in the crown of his head. And when he retreated back, Javier zoomed in and threw several punches to his side. Since he was composed of pure mana, he was an open book to Javier.

In short, the Asrahan Core Technique made Javier Pantalasa's natural enemy. Javier's oppression soon grew more systematic. Thrash here. And again. Only the painful spots. The same spot over and over. Any resistance invited more force. At last, gripped with hopelessness, Pantalasa came to a decision.

I-I have to run away.

This wasn't going to work. For some mysterious reason, this knight had an impressive ability to make fun of him. Any further opposition or combat could be his final demise. That was not the kind of ending he was hoping for.

Hmph!

Squeezing every ounce of strength he had, Pantalasa conjured up another blizzard and sent it toward Javier before swiveling around to flee the scene. But when he did, he faced another human he had forgotten about for a moment. *Fwick! Grab!*

Eh?

"Hello?" Pantalasa heard the human say as the latter dared to grab his shoulder with an aura-charged grip. He saw the man flash a brazen smile. "My name is Lloyd, and I plan on capturing you."

What? The moment Pantalasa flinched, Lloyd activated his Supercharge Skill.

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Chapter 348: A Crafty Bait (3)

“Hello? My name is Lloyd, and I am about to capture you,” he grinned, observing the elemental king flinch in shock. Despite his ghostly appearance, Lloyd detected the flustered look on his face.

Well, no surprise there.

Pantalasa's worried expression made sense. After all, he would have anticipated Javier's strikes to be the same gentle pats he received from other swordmasters in the past. The king couldn’t have imagined Javier would beat him into a pulp with his aura.

It must have hurt. The pain would’ve been something he never experienced before then. I mean, it’s coming from the aura of a grandmaster.

Lloyd's prediction that Javier's aura would be effective against the elemental king was spot on. It left the elemental in complete panic. That allowed Lloyd to move closer and capture him.

A few seconds is all I need.

Grab! Lloyd put more strength into his aura-charged hands and opened the skill window, swiftly activating the optional skill of his choice before the king could wrench himself free. He recited the widely accepted statement of “you snooze, you lose” to himself. His grip on the elemental became tighter.

Ding Dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option ⑤ : Supercharge has been activated.]

[You are absorbing a large amount of mana from surroundings at random.]

From that moment on...

Hmph.

Lloyd's eyes closed on their own before he was barely able to reaffirm his decision, his consciousness quickly fading away like a patient going under anesthesia. In the next moment, an animalistic instinct awoke inside him.

Ziiing...

The three circle chords in his heart revved up, gradually increasing in intensity. At first, they moved like a gentle spring breeze before slowly creating stronger gusts of winds and transforming into a violent storm.

Ziiing!

They went rampant, preying on everything around it, including the elemental king who was stuck by his side.

Fwoosh!

Eek!

Pantalasa, the elemental king, was initially shocked into silence. His mind blanked out from the absurd situation he was in like a video game player who got cheated, a student who showed up at the incorrect test room, or a white-collar employee who got caught bad-mouthing his boss. The only thought that occupied his mind was that he was finished. Doomed. He could only gape and helplessly flail his arms as he struggled in vain to shove Lloyd away.

This human just won’t budge...!

Pantalasa couldn’t push Lloyd away. The harder he tried to push him away, the stronger the human’s grip on him became.

Fwoosh!

Ack...!

Meanwhile, Lloyd was absorbing large amounts of mana with every passing second. Of course, it was not just from Pantalasa. He sucked in everything possible within a 22-foot radius, including rocks, snow, ice, moss, and

snowflakes. He didn’t miss anything and absorbed mana from all his surrounding sources until they were sucked dry. However, Pantalasa was the biggest victim of his absorption.

Argh!!!!

Elementals were made of pure mana, so they did not have a physical form. Instead, their bodies were like a container made of mana that held more mana inside it. These spiritual beings starkly contrasted against humans and zombies, whose bodies acted like a separate container for the mana they held. So, Lloyd's Supercharge could drain all the mana the elemental was made of and also held inside him, making it the most brutal skill Pantalasa could face.

How is it possible for a human to do this?!

Pantalasa could not believe that a mere human had such a violent ability to absorb mana. Once he got over his shock, he felt a sense of crisis.

I-I’ll really die at this rate!

His heart pounded even though he didn’t have one. A prickling sense of urgency stabbed the king across his entire body like thousands of needles. None of this was an exaggeration.

He is going to suck me dry of mana, but how can I stop him? I can't. I would do something if I had a physical form... I would try to endure against him if I did, but...

Unfortunately, he was made of mana, so there was no way for him to fight. He was completely powerless, and his feeling of impending doom was heightened by the fact that he had no idea when this violent absorption of mana would come to an end.

I can’t continue to stay still. It’ll really be the end of me if I do.

In the worst-case scenario, his entire existence could be erased. That wasn’t something he wanted. It was time for him to take action.

I have to run away!

If fighting back was impossible, the second-best option was to escape. He jumped into action right away.

To avoid being absorbed into the vortex of mana and free myself from him... Hmph!!!

Boom! Pantalasa consolidated his mana and mixed it with some icy air before creating an explosion. His actions resulted in a small storm between himself and Lloyd, pushing the human away. However, his attempt failed. Lloyd's grip on him seemed to loosen for a moment but quickly returned. *Grab!*

Eek?

Pantalasa's eyes widened as he realized Lloyd’s grasp had tightened. The man was in a trance with only one aim in mind, which was to never let go of the bastard in his grip."

H-How is this happening?!

Lloyd’s persistence against the blizzard and resolve to defeat him terrified Patalasa. He had no idea the former would have so much determination, and the situation worsened when another human joined to interrupt his escape.

Ouch!

Wham! Just then, Pantalasa felt a hard blow on the back of his head and inadvertently staggered. He instantly knew who was behind this.

It’s the silver-haired knight!

It was the silver-haired knight who had ruthlessly battered him earlier. The human was now swinging his aura-charged sword toward him.

Bam! Crash! Bam!

Pantalasa, stuck in Lloyd’s grip, was helpless against the series of strikes Javier persistently laid on the back of his head.

Ouch! Ugh! Argh!

Javier made sure each of his blows was as painful as possible and hit the same location over and over again. Pantalasa thought he was about to die from the biting pain in the back of his head while also feeling resentful of the situation at the same time.

Why? How? How is he okay when everything is losing its mana?

Pantalasa couldn’t understand. He felt cheated. But it was all because he didn’t know anything about the Asrahan Core Technique.

Why?! How is he able to move around and attack me without any issue?!

Javier was an expert in the Asrahan Core Technique, which Pantalasa was unaware of. This meant that Javier had complete control over his mana and could employ all the mana in his possession despite Lloyd's Supercharge Skill. By using the technique, not a single drop of mana was sucked out of his body. This only allowed him to move with more vigor.

Eek! Haaa! Urk!

Crash! Thwack! Clang! Pantalasa's consciousness began to wane as he was hit in the same place over and over again, heightening his sense of urgency along with it.

No... I cannot flee in this current situation. If I continue losing mana and being endlessly attacked like now... Eventually, I will lose all the mana that makes up my existence... And vanish into nothing. I will be helplessly defeated.

Chills rushed down his spine. This was the worst sense of crisis and misery he had ever felt in the range.

What should I do?

Pantalasa fell into deep thought. He drew the following conclusions. It would be the end of him if he made one wrong move from here, and he was running out of time.

In the end, this is all I can do.

Grit! Pantalasa tightly clenched the teeth he didn't have and made a decision.

I'll be killed if I stay still like now anyway... In that case, it's all or nothing.

As soon as he made a decision, the elemental king drew out all the essence of the mana that his existence was composed of. Then, he made the extracted mana condense in the most frigid air he could generate. Lastly, he fused his soul into it.

Bzzt! Instead of going for the obvious attack of setting off an explosion, Pantalasa held out the fused mass of mana with joy and launched it into the absorption path.

If you're so willing to absorb my mana... Then take this one, too!

Boom! The mass of mana entered the mana suction flow. Previously, he had been a victim of the invasion, but now he was the invader.

Let's see if the body of a mere human will be able to accept taking in all of me!

Pantalasa was 100% certain that Lloyd would blow up in a matter of seconds due to the sheer amount of mana he possessed as the elemental king of this giant mountain range.

Hmph! You must have human limitations. Even with your strength and power, you will not be able to process that much extra mana.

It was a simple principle: humans could easily drink more than one gallon of water if they drank it in small portions throughout the day. However, if they took all of it in at once, they would die due to the imbalances created throughout their body, such as in the level of sodium in their blood. They

physically couldn’t handle such a large amount of water. This was Pantalasa's plan.

Human. How dare you try to absorb my mana bit by bit? You’re wrong to think that. See who outwits you?! Pantalasa couldn’t stand the human’s insolence and wanted to eat him up in pieces. *This is my revenge! I’ll push an unmanageable amount of mana into you!*

Fwoosh! Condensed into a mass of mana essence, Pantalas invaded Lloyd’s body into his hands and flowed through his blood vessels into his heart with the intent of destroying his manaheart. However, Pantalasa was unaware that Lloyd possessed the Heart of Winter, an existence far more powerful than his essence.

Grab!

Eh?

As soon as Pantalasa walked through Lloyd's manaheart's door, he stopped in his tracks after sensing a familiar energy. When he turned around, there was a cold air mass that was much greater in size, strength, and power than him. It smiled and grabbed him by the shoulder.

Pantalasa was taken aback once more. Lloyd was not to be messed around with. The mass of cold air he held inside his heart was the size of a polar region, whereas Pantalasa's was comparable to a mountain range.

What in the world is this?

Pantalasa felt like an elementary schooler fighting a college student, a handsome local man standing between two of the sexiest men in the world, or a used car driver dangerously racing across a highway before watching a Lamborghini speed past him until it disappeared into the distance. However, despite facing the superior version of himself, he did not despair or become intimidated. Instead, he felt a sense of comfort.

It’s cozy...

This place he invaded felt like home, but it was significantly colder than the range he had lived in his entire life. Because of this, he disarmed himself against his will and awakened the homebody inside him that had been hiding for tens of thousands of years. It was so comfortable and cozy inside Lloyd that he wanted to relax for just a few tens of thousands of years since he was already here anyway.

I mean, that amount of time for an elemental like me would be the same as what a few hours is to a human.

And just like that, Pantalasa gave into the tempting impulse to settle down and rest inside this human until he died.

Just then, a string of messages appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes.

Ding Dong!

[You have absorbed the Elemental King of the Pantara Range, "Pantalasa."]

[Pantalasa wishes to reside in your manaheart.]

[If you permit him to stay, you will succeed him as "The Elemental King of the Pantara Range."]

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Chapter 349: Lloyd the Elemental King (1)

[You have absorbed the Elemental King of the Pantara Range, “Pantalasa.”]

[Pantalasa wishes to reside in your manaheart.]

[If you permit him to stay, you will succeed him in his position as “The Elemental King of the Pantara Range.”]

Still in a daze, Lloyd did not notice the new messages that appeared in front of him until two minutes later when he opened his eyes.

Ding dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 5: Your Supercharge time is up.]

Ziiing... His mana circle gradually slowed down its violent speed of rotation. The absorption of mana came to a stop.

Whoosh! Lloyd later opened his eyes to find snowflakes tapping his cheeks and eyes as the range's cold air filled the gaps left by the mana storm.

Lloyd scanned his surroundings right after opening his eyes. Then, he skillfully swept across the message before his eyes in deliberate motions.

The messages give me an idea of what happened while I was unconscious and what gains or skill I earned through the mana absorption.

This allowed him to get a grasp on how the situation developed, whether any favorable changes occurred around him, what he gained, and the decisions he needed to make. And the message that appeared this time...

This is beyond my expectations.

Gulp. Even though the message wasn’t long, Lloyd had to read it over three or four times as the content it contained was far more incredible than what he expected.

Pantalasa? I didn't know he was the elemental king who ruled over this range. And he what? Wants to reside in my manaheart?

Lloyd knew he was not dealing with an ordinary elemental and expected the spirit to have some influence over the range, which was why he decided to use the Supercharge to get rid of him. But it never occurred to Lloyd that the elemental king would make this kind of demand.

And he wants to settle inside my manaheart? What in the world?

Lloyd cocked his head to the side, unsure of how to interpret this unexpected request of some sort for permanent residence. However, one thing was certain.

If I grant his request, I will gain the authority he had as the elemental king of this range.

It was intriguing to think about ruling over the elementals around here as a human king. However, Lloyd didn't easily give in to these sorts of temptations.

Tsk. No matter how great something seems, it's better to confirm it myself.

It was a dog-eat-dog world. There wasn't anyone or anything that could be trusted. Even if something seemed great on the outside, an impulsive purchase would usually end in regret the vast majority of the time, particularly if it involved an unfamiliar product.

I mean, imagine there's a fruit drink that looks really high-quality and tasty. But then, you look at the ingredients and realize it's only three percent fruit juice. These kinds of incidents happen all the time. That's why I have to consider the benefits and drawbacks of becoming the elemental king.

The position of an elemental king seemed great at first glance. But who knew? It could be a trap. With that thought in mind, he examined the inside of his manaheart the way he used to check over the ingredients in the ten-dollar container of salt at the grocery store. Lloyd's manaheart responded immediately to his actions.

“Haah... It’s cold... It’s cozy...”

Through the lewd-sounding whispers faintly coming into his manaheart, Lloyd sensed a mass of mana that had condensed in the extremely frigid air. He recognized what the mass of mana was and tried to start a conversation with it.

“Hey. Are you Pantalasa, the elemental king of this mountain range?”

“Ha... It’s cool... It’s cozy...”

Lloyd frowned.

“Ha... This feels like home...”

“Hey.”

“Ha...”

“Do you want me to kick you out?”

“Ha?”

Dammit.

Lloyd's veins popped, and he complained like a landlord of a tenant who was twelve months behind on rent. *“Hey! What are you doing inside? Do you want to get kicked out right now?”*

The eviction warning must have worked. *“Eh? Kick me out? From here?”* asked Pantalasa.

“Yeah. You. Out. From there,” growled Lloyd.

“Can’t you postpone that decision for a bit?”

“Postpone it?” asked Lloyd in disbelief.

“Yes.”

“How long?”

“Until you die.”

Lloyd frowned in disbelief.

“I’m asking you for this favor because it’s just so perfectly cool, cozy, and comfortable here. I mean it. I’ve been alive since the day the Pantara Range rose from the ground, but it’s my first time experiencing this… refreshing cold.”

“It’s cold?” asked Lloyd. *“Do you mean the Heart of Winter?”*

“Yes. The Heart of Winter in you.” Pantalasa's voice lightly trembled, like a person experiencing culture shock or trying out an air conditioner after using a fan for their entire life. *“So, I beg you, human. I won’t ask for too much time. Can’t I stay here for a little while just until you die?”*

“Hmm... In that case, you won’t care if I destroy more of the mountains?”

“I do a little... But...”

“But what?”

“It dawned on me that this is a rare chance.”

“You mean a chance to experience the immensely refreshing cold of the Heart of Winter?”

“Yes, exactly,” replied Pantalasa. *“Human, I have been keeping a close eye on your construction. I figure you are planning to build a road across the range.”*

Lloyd nodded.

“Do you plan to construct on any other areas?”

“No,” said Lloyd. *“Probably.”*

“Well, then it’s fine.”

“I thought you were the elemental king of the range,” reminded Lloyd sharply.

“You already destroyed this area, and the range will still remain vastly untouched even if you expand a bit more from here.”

Lloyd was speechless.

“So, here’s my request. Permit me to stay here for a few decades.”

Finally, Lloyd realized this bastardly elemental king had abandoned his duties and responsibilities after being enticed by the Heart of Winter.

Well, humans are no better. I can’t expect perfection just because he’s an elemental king.

Regardless of their level of diligence, everyone wanted to slack off at times. Lloyd thought that the elemental king wouldn’t be any different.

Well, Pantalasa is basically the guardian of this range as his title suggests. I’m sure he would like to take a small break after working tirelessly since the formation of the range.

A few decades may seem long to humans. However, it was about the same amount of time as a few hours for Pantalasa, who had been alive for billions of years.

I guess it would be the same as leaving work early or taking the morning off for humans.

The comparison helped Lloyd understand where Pantalasa was coming from. But it didn’t mean that he’d easily grant the latter’s request right away.

“Then, let me ask you one thing,” said Lloyd.

“What is it, human?”

“What do I gain from granting your request?” asked Lloyd expectantly.

“You will have the power to reign over this range for a few decades.”

“No,” said Lloyd impatiently. *“Tell me specifically what I gain from earning the title of the elemental king.”*

Lloyd needed to hear the answer to this question. How could he not?

I don’t want to blindly trust his words that it’s a good thing and regret it later.

Lloyd was being serious. It was a painful lesson he had learned throughout the course of his life. Regret was an inevitable outcome if he blindly trusted other people’s words. Lloyd never wanted to follow in the footsteps of his parents, who were scammed into bankruptcy, or Count and Countess Frontera, who were previously on the verge of bankruptcy. He wanted to carefully go over everything one by one instead of being swayed with empty words of persuasion.

This is a mistake people make when people buy stocks or other investments. A group of people suddenly praise a company, and everyone rushes to buy their stocks. Then, the stock prices plummet, and they're forced to hold onto them for dear life. The same thing happened with bitmoney. There was a boom in demand for the currency at one point in time. But what happened to the people who rashly went into it?

Instead of hitting the jackpot like they expected, they were all hit with plummeting prices.

I don’t want to end up like them. The same is true now.

This was his plan: Hear the pros and cons of becoming an elemental king in detail. Pantalasa responded.

“First... It feels nice.”

“I don’t care...” said Lloyd, struck dumb. *“Be more specific.”*

“Be more specific, you say... Hmm... You can summon and command the elementals in this range.”

“Command? However I please?”

“Probably,” replied Pantalasa. *“If the others accept you as the elemental king. You will then have absolute control over the elementals in the range. At least, within this mountain range.”*

“Are you sure? I have some doubts.”

“Why do you have doubts?”

“You didn’t call for any other elementals when you fought with us. Why is that?” Lloyd asked sharply.

“I let my guard down. It never occurred to me that being hit by a human could hurt so much, and there was one who could absorb my mana so relentlessly.”

“Hmm...” mulled Lloyd.

“I mean it. I was able to easily take care of the swordmasters that I encountered before by myself. So, I assumed it’d be similar this time and didn’t think that there would be a need to disrupt their break by calling for them. But I was wrong.”

“Hmm...”

Pantalasa’s answer made sense. The next question followed.

“Great. If the upside is gaining command over the elementals in this range, what’s the downside?”

“Nothing,” replied Pantalasa confidently.

“Nothing?”

“Nothing.”

“I smell something fishy.”

“Fishy?”

“Fishy. Like you’re trying to scam me.”

“*I’m not. I’m being honest right now. Just make sure not to destroy the range too badly. That’s all I ask from you.”*

“Not much damage?” asked Lloyd.

“Yeah.” The elemental king continued to speak. *“Once the range sees too much damage, the elementals will grumble and find another home. You let that keep happening, and you will lose support from the elementals.”*

“You mean a riot would break out?”

“Yeah. A riot. That’s all you should need to watch out for.”

Hmm... Lloyd pondered for a second about the possibility of the other elementals raising a coup if he enacted too much damage on the land here. He chuckled. *“I won’t lose anything. Well, I’ll hand over the position if someone throws a coup.”*

“What?”

“The position wasn’t mine in the first place anyway. Why obsess over it? All I need is for the construction to end well. So I see. I’ll grant your request.”

“H-Hold on! What do you mean you can always pass over my title to someone else? What do you mean by that?”

“Oh, your request is granted. Enjoy your decades’ worth of rest.”

Ding Dong!

The moment Lloyd voiced out his consent, Pantalasa’s voice faded out, and messages appeared in front of his eyes.

[You have accepted the request of Elemental King Pantalasa.]

[You have now become the “Acting Elemental King of the Pantara Range.”]

[You can reign over the range until you die or hand over the power to some other elemental.]

[From now on, you have the unrivaled ability to summon elementals from anywhere in the range and locate their exact location.]

Whew...

Lloyd exhaled a sigh after checking the message. What Pantalasa said was true. Messages appeared in series as soon as he permitted the stay. Feeling content, he looked at the side.

“Are you okay, Young Master?” Javier asked as if he had been waiting. Lloyd noticed the cold gaze distinct to Javier.

Lloyd knew that the coldness was a mask to hide Javier’s concern for him. With a smile on his face, Lloyd said, “As you can see.”

“Then... The elemental...”

“I absorbed him. And now, I have become the elemental king of this range.”

“...”

“I’m serious,” pressed Lloyd.

“...”

“I’m serious.”

“...”

“If you doubt me, then relax your face and ask me a question.”

“It is not that I am doubting you,” replied Javier. “However...”

“However?”

“I suddenly pity the elementals who have to serve a man like you as their king,” Javier said. “The elementals will soon be sent to the construction site, where they will be treated as nothing more than construction equipment day in and day out. They will be drawn into exploitation with an overtime bonus and so on. I can see it happen as clear as day.”

Lloyd was quiet for a moment.

“Am I wrong?”

“Yeah. That’s how you’ve been treated until now.”

Javier seemed pensive.

“I’m only an evil contractor to you,” quipped Lloyd. “That’s why I’m getting started right at this moment.”

“Start what?”

“What else? To delegate chores to the elementals, I’ll have to make them respect me. Set up a clear order.”

“Order?”

“Well,” Lloyd said with a grin, his gaze running the length of the range that extended below the steep range, where he intended to put his newly acquired power to good use. “Let us give these elementals a taste of physical labor. First come, first served.”

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Chapter 350: Lloyd the Elemental King (2)

Assemble. It was a common term in South Korea. There would be some who associated the word with the first chapter of the physics textbook they vigorously studied as a student. However, most men would immediately think back to their days in the military. Morning roll call. Move to the cafeteria. Assemble for training and work. Evening roll call. They spent their entire day getting into assembles over and over again. Thus, the memories of their time in the military were tinged with trauma for many veterans.

But to the elementals residing in this range, the assemble order Lloyd, a human from South Korea, issued was a mysterious enigma. And so, gathered at the sixth highest peak of the range, the six high-level elementals gazed at each other with confusion in their eyes.

“Oh, rock elemental,” said the pine tree elemental. “It has been a while.”

“It’s been a while, yes, Pine Tree Elemental. Where is Heavy Snow?” asked the rock elemental.

“There.” The pine tree elemental pointed to a side. “Frost Moss. Icicle. Crevasse. Everyone’s here.”

“I guess I am the last one to arrive,” said the rock elemental with a sigh.

“Perhaps.”

“I do not know if I will be able to look the elemental king in his face.”

“It’s fine,” comforted the pine tree elemental. “This is the first time the elemental king summoned us all to one place.”

“Indeed,” said the rock elemental, feeling a little better. “This has never happened before. I wonder why he summoned us all.”

“Probably because of the humans,” said the pine tree elemental, the guardian of all needleleaf trees in the Pantara Range. “Humans recently arrived and wreaked havoc on the place.”

“Ah. That was difficult for me, too. They pushed away two peaks and widened the rift between them by force.”

“Awful, really. I presume the elemental king is furious because of it.”

“You have a point. This marks the biggest event since the range came to be.”

“Event...? More like a disaster,” corrected the pine tree elemental.

“Right. It was a disaster.”

The pine tree elemental and the rock elemental sadly nodded, sharing similar sentiments on the situation. They joined the others in waiting for the elemental king to appear. After much waiting, they were finally met with the elemental king. However, the king was not Pantalasa, the one they had been waiting for.

Grab!

“Whew...! My back, goodness. I should have chosen another location,” said the voice as a hand popped and grabbed onto the edge of the cliff from below. Soon, the face of a human soaked in sweat emerged. He climbed up the peak with great struggle, seemingly flushed red from being out of breath.

The high-level elementals clamped their mouths in surprise and dismay as a human appeared. No one knew how to react. Everyone stared blankly at the human.

But the attitude of the human, Lloyd, showed was outlandishly different from theirs. After collecting his breath with a simple “Whew!” he dusted off the snow on his clothes and straightened them before flashing a grin at the elementals. “You all kindly showed up early for assembly!”

His manner of speech was too laid back. He seemed to have expected their reaction. At that moment, the high-level elementals were in a state of shock. Was it because of the relaxed and brazed attitude of the human who suddenly appeared in front of them? No. It was because they felt the power of the elemental king from him!

Impossible!

His humanity was undeniable. No matter where they looked, he was a human with two arms and legs. However, there was no denying the power of the elemental king within him. The elementals could clearly feel it.

How's this possible? I mean, is it even possible?

All the elementals were in disbelief. This was against all common sense. It was illogical. How could there be a human elemental king? And yet, such an absurd existence was right in front of them, slowly coming toward their direction.

"What are you all doing there? Do you plan on dazing out all day after putting in the effort to assemble here?" asked Lloyd with a mischievous smile.

Lloyd's question jostled them out of trance. The first one to come to his senses was the rock elemental. "Human! What are you?!"

"What else?" Lloyd drawled. "I am the elemental king of this range. Is that not obvious?"

"No, I mean! How? Where is our elemental king?"

"Your elemental king? You mean Pantalasa?"

"Yes! Pantalasa, our ruler and guardian of the range! Where did he go to while there's a human like you emitting his power?!"

"Oh, he's on vacation," replied Lloyd casually.

"What...?" the rock elemental stopped in shock.

Lloyd’s lips curled up meaningfully. “I’m serious. He said he found a cooler place that’s cooler and cozier than here. So, he told me he wanted to take a break for a while.”

“How long...”

“For a few decades. He said he’ll return once I die.”

The rock elemental gaped in disbelief.

“Honestly, we have to give him that. I heard his story, and it’s pitiful. He has been working for millions of years without taking a single break. Isn’t that so sad? Imagine how much he would have wanted to rest. Besides, I heard a few decades is nothing for you all.”

“That’s true, but—”

“So what, you can’t accept me as the elemental king?” challenged Lloyd.

“I can't!” the rock elemental yelled in response to Lloyd's provocative question, but he was not alone. Everyone did, some even floating their bodies in the air in a threatening manner or exuding cold energy. The message was clear, and Lloyd knew what it meant.

“Tsk. That’s it? You can’t accept me as your elemental king because I’m a human.” Lloyd chuckled, having expected this to happen. He figured their reaction was only obvious.

I mean, if a company I worked for my whole life lost their president and a cat randomly appeared one day and said, “Meow! I’m your president starting today!” No one would accept the change.

Not in a million years. Lloyd thought the situation was pretty much the same right now.

And that’s why I only assembled the high-level elementals.

Getting accepted by the elementals was an obstacle that needed to be cleared before Lloyd could command the elementals within range, even

though he was fortunate enough to inherit the powers of the elemental king.

Imagine how many elementals are in this range. It'd be a waste of time to call for each one of them and get their recognition. That'd be too inefficient.

As such, Lloyd decided to round up only the high-level elementals as the rest under them would follow accordingly.

The elementals are all put into a strict ranking system, which includes the elemental king, high-level, intermediate-level, and low-level. It's similar to how it is in the military, meaning you only have to properly educate the highest ranks.

After that, the remaining work would go off without a hitch. The high ranks would vent their frustrations out on those below them. Then, those individuals would then repeat the cycle to the ranks below them.

Until the lowest soldier anonymously reports to the commanders. But there's nothing to worry about that here. No one can report things anonymously.

This was Lloyd's justification for calling in only the most powerful elementals. His recently acquired rank made it simpler for him to issue the summoning order in his heart, from which it spread like text messages. With a grin on his face, he considered the purpose and meaning of the call, saying, "I know you cannot accept me as your elemental king, but I have some things to tell you as your rightful ruler. I do not work with those who do not listen to me, so I am going to give you a choice. Accept me as your king or deny me and bid your life as an elemental farewell."

Everyone fell into silence.

"Silent treatment? That's how you're responding."

Once again, everyone remained silent. They simply glowered at Lloyd in defiance.

Lloyd, on the other hand, smiled more suspiciously as though he had anticipated this and therefore arrived with a secret weapon. “First, you,” he said, pointing to the pine tree elemental that was displaying aggression due to anxiety. “Your body, that is, your home address is the biggest and oldest pine tree at the peak of the timberline in the direction of the ridge. I can see it. Yes, I am right. I will beat you up first.”

Lloyd then smiled and raised his hand, which was holding a shovel.

Kaboom! The shovel's mana blast shot high into the sky and disappeared from view after lighting a corner. Next moment...

“Ack!” the pine tree elemental lurched forward and fell, glaring at Lloyd with pain. “What have you done to my body?!”

“What do you think?” Lloyd smiled nonchalantly. “I cut a branch of your tree.”

“H-How?!”

“How else? My knight did after I sent a signal.”

The pine tree elemental gave him an agitated expression. The branch the human broke had been one he was the proudest of and especially cherished and cared for due to its exceptionally beautiful and trim appearance. However, it was cut off without hesitation by the henchmen Lloyd sent out in advance. The elemental angrily questioned how this could happen.

“This is just the start, and I can tell from your eyes that you figured that out already. This will make things easier for us,” Lloyd merely said, pulling a brazen face. “Do you want me to use your tree trunk for construction? How about letting it go for just a few decades?”

The pine tree elemental let out an appalled “Eek.” The offer was clearly a threat veiled in a proposal. Take it or perish. There were only two options. The elemental thought over it for a while. Then, Lloyd dangled a sweet offer in front of it.

“Think about it,” came Lloyd’s voice to allure the pine tree elemental. “I’m not asking for something grand. Just accept me as your king since I already have the authority for it. Accept me as I am.”

The pine tree elemental continued to think without saying anything.

“Still don’t feel like it? Because I’m a human? What are you? Xenophobes? No, right? And besides, it’s not like I’m going to order anything outrageous,” urged Lloyd.

“But you destroyed the peak-”

“That was unavoidable, and that’s why I’m asking your help here. Some help with the weather and in difficult areas during the work.”

“...”

“But I promise you that no human will ever set foot in the areas outside the construction area. I give you my word. This won’t be harmful to you. Can’t we reach an agreement?”

“...”

“Well,” said Lloyd feigned wistfulness, “If you still don’t feel like it, you can always say goodbye to your elemental life and become a construction material.”

The pine tree elemental scowled at the thought.

This time, Lloyd’s gaze moved to Elemental Icicle. “And you, Elemental Icicle. You’re relieved now because you think I won’t be able to make good use of you since you’re ice, no?”

The icicle elemental, who was closely watching over the situation, flinched.

Lloyd flashed an evil smile. “You have my promise that you won’t be safe even if you’re an icicle. What’s your future aspiration?”

“What?” The icicle elemental asked.

“Do you like beef soup? Clear soup? Or spicy soup?”

“...”

“What do you want to be? Which option would be the most rewarding death for you?”

Gulp. The icicle elemental took a deep breath, and it dawned on everyone present that the human's threats were not a lie or an exaggeration. They were real and serious. In other words, they were backed into a corner by a complete madman with no common sense. The elementals exchanged glances with one another, and after a brief debate session, they made a decision.

“Fine. We will accept you as our ruler.” They all then bowed at Lloyd. Just a few decades like this. Keep their heads low. That was the price of not being extinguished.

Lloyd smiled. “Great. You’re making the right choice. Okay, then. It’s time to sprint to celebrate this moment.”

“Eh?” Everyone said in unison.

“I said,” Lloyd said in a clear voice, “Sprint. Touch the rock over there. The first five will get a special pardon for resisting me back there. The last one to come, however... You better be prepared.”

“I don’t get what’s happening...” The elementals’ facial expressions shook.

Lloyd's face hardened into a smile. He knew that these elementals’ obedience was fleeting and superficial. Eventually, they would try to rebel and take control of Lloyd. Therefore, the time had come for him to establish a permanent order, one that would make it easier for him to manage them. “You all have attitude issues? Slack around like this, and you will end up last.”

When they finally understood the situation, the race started. That was when Lloyd truly became the elemental king of the range, with thousands of

elementals submitting to him.

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Chapter 351: Switchback System (1)

“It has already been nineteen years since I began ruling over thousands of elite forces... How did this happen...?”

Beyond the vast and steep Pantara Range, to the southwest of the Magentano Kingdom, lay the Benetto Kingdom. Within the palace that sat in the capital, King Benettogna heaved a long, drawn breath upon realizing that he was facing the greatest disaster of his kingdom since its founding 300 years ago.

King Benettogna enquired, “So what happened after the peaks were torn down? Has there been a change in the dragon’s movement?”

“Please forgive me, Your Majesty. We have not been able to determine that yet.”

“Hmm... Then...”

“From what we believe, there is a high possibility that the Magentano Kingdom's army will attack us through the demolished peaks.”

“Yes, they probably will.” The king nodded, his face serious. It was an accurate and logical prediction. “Since the very founding of our kingdom, the rugged terrain of the Pantara Range has served as a natural shield that protects us. However, judging from the demolished peaks, I believe that Alicia, the greedy she-devil of Magentano, intends on showing her true colors.”

“Your Majesty, our kingdom’s army is also nothing to look down on. We will block their intrusion even at the risk of our own lives.”

“Do you believe that’s possible?” asked the king.

“We have defended this land for the past 300 years, during which we vigilantly prepared against the invasion of a powerful nation. The Magentano army may be powerful, but they will inevitably become

exhausted as they cross the Pantara Range," the supreme commander of the defense forces retorted with a firm gaze.

"Would that be our chance to strike?" asked the king.

"Yes, Your Majesty. No matter how mighty the army is, they won't be able to mount a proper defense against our ambush in their state of exhaustion after crossing the range."

The king nodded. "Yes. That's what I desperately hope will happen."

The commander was right. They realistically had no way of preventing the Magentano Kingdom from invading their land. Their only potential window of opportunity for success would be when the soldiers of Magentano were in a vulnerable state of exhaustion from crossing the mountain range.

"In other words, the fate of our kingdom depends on that one ambush," remarked the king ruefully.

"Please trust me, Your Majesty."

"All right. I will trust you then," replied the king. "So, please swiftly go into combat with our most nimble and powerful army of soldiers."

"I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty!"

The Benetto Kingdom was located just thirty miles from the Pantara Range as its founders believed that proximity to the mountains was the best form of protection they could have. However, the opposite was true now, and there would be immediate danger of invasion the moment the Magentano troops marched down the range. If there was any consolation, it was that the short distance from the range would allow them to promptly respond to enemy attacks.

Watching the commander disappear, the king prayed, "May our kingdom's late predecessors grant us the power to overcome this crisis..." And he fervently hoped that the operation would succeed in maintaining peace over Benetto. His heart raced with desperation and anxiety. However, his

concerns were completely unnecessary. To begin with, the Magentano Kingdom had no plans for any invasion. Instead, there was only a civil engineer advancing a construction project to build a road through the range. Nevertheless, a moment later, the kingdom suddenly froze in place. *Bzzt...!*

It was the work of the Time Freeze skill, which had been activated thirty miles away from Benetto in the Pantara Range. The palace walls, floor, and ceiling froze, and that wasn't the end of it. The flag that swayed in the wind on the palace terrace, the drifting clouds in the sky, the countless people moving through the capital city, the flows of water, and leaves falling down to the ground stilled inside the kingdom. The flow of time froze across all surrounding areas and even the rest of the world beyond them without exception.

***

[Skill Option 5: Time Freeze has been activated.]

[You have spent 3,000 RP.]

[Current RP: 7,071]

Crackle...!

[Time has been frozen.]

[The no-freeze zone cannot be changed until the optional skill is canceled.]

[The option is deactivated in the event the user goes out of the no-freeze zone.]

[Any creature within the range of the no-freeze zone will not age for a year.]

Lloyd watched the messages appear in front of him one by one. He felt an odd sensation of a tremendous volume of icy air departing his manaheart and the Heart of Winter.

"Haah..."

Lloyd rushed into action for the following phase now that the flow of time had been frozen.

Time to work!

Lloyd immediately dispatched a team of laborers he had assembled in advance, as the construction had been delayed for days due to the snowstorm. Thus, the Pantara Range Railroad Project took off. And because Draggy did such an excellent job carving out, plowing, and flattening the ground for the railway, everyone was able to begin building the roadbed immediately.

“My dear orc warriors, I am proud of you,” said Lloyd. “I remember giving you one important piece of information before we began. Do you recall?”

“If the water doesn’t drain in the railroad, the soil in the foundation will leak, oink!”

“What did I compare it to?” asked Lloyd again.

“Muscle loss, oink!!” said an orc passionately.

“So, what should we do?”

“Waterway! Build a trackside drainage! Oink!”

Lloyd believed the drainage to be the most important part of this project.

The land is steep here. Moreover, there’s snow falling, melting, and freezing on the ground all year round.

The melted snow would seep into the ground, eventually causing soil erosion from the runoff water and creating a sinkhole or another disaster. Alternatively, the trapped water could freeze and damage the railway by causing the ground to expand and protrude upwards.

If that happens, we are screwed. That’s why building drainage is our top priority. There will be laborers cleaning the railway when it snows as well, but that won’t be enough.

He needed the remaining snow and ice to flow out into the drainage. Thus, the design for it had to be precise so that all the water would flow out in the right path and direction without damaging the roadbed. As such, he closely supervised the construction of trackside drainage as he worked on the roadbed, making sure that it was made where the upper slope met the lower tracks.

“Dig, oink!”

“Carve out, oink!”

“Stomp, oink!”

“Date, oink!”

“There’s a traitor here...Oink!”

On the other hand, the elves were responsible for stabilizing the slope.

“Okay. Sprinkle water on the slope before the water in the bucket freezes?” asked Moira, the leader of the elves.

Lloyd grinned. “Yes, that is all I need you to do. The slope is quite steep, but it’s comprised of bedrock.” It was true. The exposed bedrock in the area was all thanks to Draggy’s joyous destruction of the slope. Lloyd experimented with his virtual simulation and found that there was no risk of a collapse. However, he would need to do something about the potential weathering. “As time passes, small pebbles or larger rock fragments will break off the bedrock and roll down to the railway, possibly damaging it. If we are unlucky, the train could face a disruption while it’s running. Otherwise, there could be a derailment if something lands on top of a rail. This can all be avoided by sprinkling water on the slope’s surface, where it’ll immediately freeze into a coating of ice.”

If it wasn’t installed properly, the freeze-thaw cycle could cause the cement to lift, crack, and have all kinds of other problems. Instead of dealing with that disaster, it was much easier and more effective to freeze a layer of water on the ground.

It’s not that the ice won’t melt at all. However, whatever does will be quickly replaced by the heavy snow falling and freezing on top of it.

To keep the ice from becoming too thick, he would probably need to cut it down more frequently. However, that could wait until after his current work was complete. “I will leave you to it then. Also, please make sure to use the safety rope since it is slippery up there.”

“Don’t worry. This is no different than plain land for us.” Moira chuckled. She and the elves then proceeded to move with the agility of a circus troupe.

Swoosh! Fwip!

The steep and slippery slope was nothing to them. It was as simple as 1+1 was for a high school valedictorian, learning to dribble was for Michael Jordan, or punching bubble wrap was for Mike Tyson. The elves treaded, rushed, and leaped around to sprinkle water around the slick slope before coming back to draw more water and repeat the process. At the same time, Ggoming spewed two layers of spiderweb on top of the layer of ice they created. Seeing that the construction of the slope protection went well, Lloyd moved on to the next task, which was the railroad construction.

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

Fwish!

Every day, Bangul produced rebars, which Corgidus and his team refined to fit precisely as Lloyd had designed. These pieces were then brought to the site to be installed and assembled by skeletons, lancers, and civil engineers. The railroads progressed day by day as more drains were made, gravel was laid out, timber was placed, and rails were installed. Above the site, the elves continued to sprinkle water on the bedrock to freeze its surface. All of this was made possible by Lloyd's vast and exceptional experience with numerous large-scale projects.

Duh. It’s horrible to be wasteful!

In Lloyd's mind, this was the perfect construction site: nothing was wasted, safety came first, and everyone worked happily. Just like that, three months went by, and by then, a rough outline of the railroad ascending the mountain had appeared.

“I suppose this is the loop line railway and switchback system you mentioned the last time.”

“That’s exactly right.” Lloyd grinned and looked at Javier. “Why? Is this your first time seeing something like it?”

As Javier looked down at the ground below, he moaned at the ridiculousness of Lloyd’s question and saw the result of their three months of labor beneath him. The loop railroad was the first feature that caught his eye.

It looks like a snake circling the mountain.

That was the first thing that came to mind when he looked at the railroad. It was not straight like the normal ones. Instead, it was looped, and the train went around the mountain rather than up it. The principle of the railroad was clear to Javier even if he was not an expert engineer.

And the switchback... Can a train move in a place like that?

Lloyd frowned as he examined one point in the rift, which was the steepest area with the up line. There was a zigzag railway along the slope, but it was not connected like the loop type. Instead, it was cut off on one side and connected to the other side via a crossing.

I suppose the train will move forward and backward over and over again along the railway on the slope in a zigzag mode, climbing up little by little.

Javier furrowed his brows after discovering the idea behind the switchback system. He wondered if it was safe because he wasn’t sure that the train could maneuver precisely in the zigzag railway, given how narrow it was. One tiny error and the passenger would undoubtedly fall off.

But I’m sure Master Lloyd has a plan.

He probably does have a plan. It was Lloyd after all. Thinking so, Javier assured himself.

“Good. It’s your first time. Then, watch me ride that thing.” said Lloyd.

“Excuse me...” muttered Javier, taken aback, trying to figure out if he heard correctly. Master Lloyd was going to ride that untested thing? Feeling anxious, he turned and looked at Lloyd. “That can’t be. Young Master?”

“That’s right. I’m going to test it.”

“But why should you-”

“Because it’s dangerous,” Lloyd said, smiling as if testing anything dangerous was clearly part of his job description.

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Chapter 352: Switchback System (2)

“It’s dangerous. That’s why,” Lloyd grinned, thinking that was the obvious answer. “Moreover, a test run like the one we went through in Hell is a necessary step that we cannot skip. I’ve found that you have to ride a train and railway yourself to get a proper feel for it. It’s hard to determine how well made each section is, how close the final product is to what was envisioned during the construction phase, what specific improvements are needed for certain sections, and if there are any unstable areas or safety hazards without looking over everything with your own eyes and physically experiencing a ride.”

Lloyd was serious. There were things he couldn’t find out before going on a ride to see and experience them for himself. He continued, “So I have to go on a ride. I asked Corgidus in advance if he could create a development mule for the test run. I glanced at it earlier, and it looked quite phenomenal.”

“Hmm, Master Lloyd,” said Javier. “That is not what I meant to say...”

“That’s not it? What is it then?” Lloyd smiled again, cocking his head to the side.

Javier’s face grew stern. “I am aware of the need for a test drive and why someone needs to get the ride experience. But my question is why you should be the one to do it.”

“I told you a while ago. I need to directly see and feel everything for myself.”

“Can you not ask someone else to do the job?”

“Nope. I can’t.”

“But it is dangerous,” insisted Javier, pointing to the railroad built along the steep slope. “It may look all right on the outside, but no one knows what kind of dangers might appear when it’s in operation. My suggestion is to

run a safety check first without anyone on before you go ahead with your plan.”

“Hmm, that won’t work.”

“Why is that?” asked Javier.

“Because of the orcs,” explained Lloyd. “Even with no other passengers, the orcs will be on the ride since the train moves from the exerted force of the lever being pressed down. It would be pretty weird for me to opt out just because it is dangerous while I have the orcs onboard. Do you want me to turn into a piece of trash?”

“Well...”

“Leave it,” said Lloyd conclusively. “I know you’re saying this out of concern, but I’ve got a plan. So you can rest assured.”

“You have safety measures in mind?” asked Javier.

“Of course.” Lloyd nodded confidently and declared with a bright smile, “You are coming with me.”

“...”

“That way, I wouldn’t feel too wronged even if the train derails and I fall off a cliff.”

“In other words, you aren’t willing to die alone.”

“That, too, obviously.”

Lloyd smiled widely and continued, “I am just kidding. You are a great asset that could help me and the orcs escape if needed. But I will have Draggy on standby near us so he can catch the train if it rolls off.”

Since the test drive came with risks, there needed to be safety measures put into place. That went without saying.

Of course. I've got to have safety measures in place.

Lloyd was genuinely afraid of the test drive, to be honest. However, he never even considered delegating the task to someone else. The responsibility was his and his alone.

As I told Javier, I have to inspect the results of the construction. But a bigger reason is the danger that comes with it.

Lloyd believed it was only appropriate that he shoulder the danger himself. He needed to take on the risks that came with testing the train as the person who designed it.

There will be countless people who ride the train once it's in operation. So, it would honestly be absurd for me not to participate in a test ride for a train I designed myself because it's dangerous.

Lloyd was disgusted with the thought of making something for other people that he wouldn't use due to safety concerns. However, he had seen this happen from time to time back in Korea.

It occurred a lot on construction sites. That was how safety measures were handled most of the time. I've rarely seen those in charge ever inspect or install the safety nets, tower cranes, and passageways that would be used by the dozens of workers on site.

Instead, they threw the jobs to their employees and some other workers, who simply glanced over them on paper, and there were even those who completely skipped those parts.

I used to curse those types of people inside my head all the time. And yet, I would be no different than them if I made someone else do the test ride in my place because it could be dangerous.

That was not what Lloyd wanted. He felt that in order to be confident about his past self, the risk was his burden to take.

“Anyway, I am going to be on the train for a few reasons. There are a lot of safety precautions in place, so there is nothing to worry about. And if we ever die together, consider it an honor,” Lloyd said, laughing once more.

“An honor? That won’t happen.”

“What? Are you going to save me if the train falls off?”

“No. I’m going to escape alone.”

“...”

“But fine. I will give you a proper farewell.”

“...”

“I could even sadly wave my hands if you want.”

“Tsk, never mind.” Lloyd then burst into laughter.

A faint smile appeared on Javier’s face, and he thought... *Despite his tendency to act conceited and self-centered, Master Lloyd never handed his responsibilities to someone else during the most important moments.*

Javier initially believed Lloyd to be nothing but conniving. The definition of an opportunist. However, he realized later that this was just his way of survival. That was how Lloyd learned to survive while living somewhere called Seoul. Beneath his false exterior, there was an admirable selflessness and effort to lead a life he could be proud of.

And so, I may somehow come to admire you one day.

Javier thought these were likely his true feelings for Lloyd. Although, he honestly didn’t want to admit that and had even less desire to ever make his feelings known. Thinking this, the silver-haired knight laughed and looked at the construction site on the slope next to Lloyd.

***

From that day on, Lloyd sat down to begin the test drive of the train. He focused most of his attention on the process of choosing the orc warriors who would get the test train to start moving. “I am planning to have eight volunteers in each car of the train.”

“Oink?”

The 300 orc warriors snorted in disinterest at Lloyd's words. The task seemed so dull and unappealing that they worried they would lose their muscles. They thought that using shovels and pickaxes to dig and plow the site would be a more beneficial activity. However, what Lloyd said next changed their opinions altogether.

“Anybody wants to take this opportunity to train their triceps by working as a volunteer?”

“Triceps...? Oink?” Everyone’s eyes flew open with interest, and their snort turned heated and excited.

“Oink! Does it mean that our triceps will grow larger and more beautiful, oink?” An interested orc raised his hand.

“Of course. The train will move using the muscles of those selected. Its wheels will roll forward from the force that’s exerted as the lever for the train is pushed down in a pumping motion,” Lloyd explained with the smile of a swindler.

“Push exercises! Triceps, oink!”

“Indeed, it will give your triceps a serious workout. Moreover, since half of the journey is up a steep slope, moving the train will be more difficult, requiring more strength. And that means-”

“More stimulation, oink!”

“Yes, precisely. You are going to get jacked, and since you will have to pump the lever nonstop, you will also gain better endurance.”

“Tireless muscle! Oink!”

“Yes, that’s what I’m saying. Okay, let me ask you again. Who’s up for a tricep workout?”

“Me, oink!”

“No! Me, oink!”

“I will do it, oink!”

As soon as Lloyd had finished speaking, there was a ruckus among the orc warriors. After a tirade of arm wrestling, eight winners were chosen. Then, Lloyd added two more “sand men” on top of them.

“Okay, you two are the sand men,” said Lloyd, “Take this.”

“Oink? What is this? Aren’t these sandbags, oink?”

“Yes.” Lloyd flashed a grin after handing over a large bag of sand to them. “Your job from now on is very important.”

“Important? Us? Oink?”

“Yes. You will be at the very front of the train. Do you see the chairs furnished outside?”

“Yes, I do, oink.”

“Looks like a special seat, oink!”

There were two seats fixed on the front of the train head where Lloyd pointed. “You might wonder what they are doing outside when they should be inside, but there is a reason. That is where you two would vouch for the safety of the train as you battle the harsh wind.”

“Brave the gust of biting wind, oink?”

“Responsible for the safety of the train? Us? Oink?”

“Yes. The safety of the train rests on your shoulders.” Lloyd pointed to the large sandbags in their embraces. “Throughout the ride, I want you two to sprinkle sand on the railroad.

“Sand, oink?”

“What happens if we sprinkle sand, oink?”

“That will allow the train to move more smoothly without slipping off the rail, thanks to the friction the sand creates.”

Lloyd was right about this. And his idea wasn’t entirely his. It was borrowed from the actual method in South Korea.

The train that ran the Himalayan Darjeeling Railway, which served as the model for this one, featured sand men.

This idea originated from research materials fashioned by Lloyd’s college senior, and it concerned the real sand men in the Darjeeling train, who behaved just like the rocs here. Thanks to them, the train moved through the slopes more steadily.

“So your role is very important. The safety of this train will depend on how meticulously and precisely you sprinkle sand on the railway.”

“Our role is vital, oink!”

“We are important, oink!”

“Yes. Without you two, this train won’t move. So please do a good job.”

“You can leave it to us, oink!”

“Trust us, oink!” Two orcs tapped their pecs, having learned of their job as sand men.

Finally, the test run began, and it was during this that the extraordinary value of Corgidus and his team, who built the test train, became evident.

“Start!”

“Oink! Oink!”

Clack! Clank! Clank...! With Lloyd's go signal, the orcs' triceps powerfully contracted. The four of them grabbed the lever and pressed it with overwhelming strength, pumping it down as if there was no tomorrow. The orcs' propulsion caused the one-car train to move forward, and the sand men sprayed sand at the front. The travel was slow at first as it climbed the mountain, but whenever the orcs showed signs of fatigue...

“Time for a shift change. What did I say is more important than exercise to build muscle?”

“Proper rest, oink!” The four orcs stepped back with that united shout.

Subsequently, another four orcs arrived and grabbed the lever; four orcs made up one group. As one group ran out of steam, the other stepped in. The train ascended the rift's slope just like this. Eventually, the train reached a point where the slope grew too steep for the orcs to keep pumping the lever. However, Lloyd had no concerns about it.

“And that’s why I used the switchback system to pass through these kinds of areas.”

He gave Javier a confident smile as he inspected the railway and yelled, “Stop!” to the orcs who were pumping. At the same time, they pulled the halt lever.

Clunk! Squeaak! When the train came to a stop at the dead-end section of the railway, the metallic wheel clunked as it was locked, and Javier thought...

It looks like the railway is cut off here. How will the train move around?

Javier was extremely curious, and his curiosity grew upon hearing Lloyd yell.

“Sand men! Cardio! Now!”

At that moment, the sand men leaped to their feet, enabling the train to move across the steep slopes thanks to the brilliant switchback system.

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Chapter 353: Switchback System (3)

The switchback system was a technique used to run trains on rocky terrains. It was simple in theory: the train moved forward, changed tracks, and moved backward until it changed tracks again. Rinse and repeat. To put it another way, the switchback system allowed a train to travel up a slope at the lowest elevation possible through a zig-zag shape.

Well, roads can also be built similarly to the old highway in Chupungnyeong. There are also many paths going up mountain slopes in a zig-zag pattern throughout Hongcheon, Pyeongchang, and Inje County in the Province of Gangwon. This arrangement made the routes easier to drive through since the incline of the roads became gentler as the distance of travel increased.

A similar switchback system was also once used in South Korea. The stations between Heungjeon and Nahanjeong, as well as the paths in the Gyeongbu Line and Chukhang Line, were representative examples, though they were now closed.

There are plenty more in other places, too, of course. In addition to the one in Darjeeling, India, there are also similar railways in Mountain Ali, Taiwan, Peru, Germany, the United States, and many more.

Of course, the one Lloyd built here was considerable in scale. It was actually over the top.

Eight? Five? Nah. Twenty-one times!

To climb over the rift's hill, the train would need to switch directions twenty-one times.

Even though twenty-one is a lot, this is still manageable. After all, if Draggy had not removed two peaks and expanded the rift, I don’t think even 210 switchbacks would have been enough let alone twenty-one.

Lloyd had already tried to lower the number of switchbacks that would be needed as much as he could. While looking at his final design in contentment, he shouted, “Sand men, it’s time for cardio!”

At Lloyd’s yelling, the sand men dropped the bag of sand and dashed outside the train while remembering Lloyd’s warning. They then pushed the massive lever planted in the area where they ran, and a small change occurred on the track the test train had passed through. *Clack! Creeak!*

The railway segment changed directions. The train was cut off from the rails behind it and connected to another track in a different direction ahead of it, opening up a new path uphill. Once the two sand men completed their mission, they went back to the train and gave Lloyd a thumbs up.

“Switch completed! Oink!”

“Good.”

It was Lloyd’s turn to work now. After confirming the switch in tracks, he pulled the lever, a basic geared device that created a simple back-and-forth movement, on both sides of the train’s braking device.

Clank! Lloyd yelled, “Go!” as the reverse gear clicked into place.

The orcs then began to pump the lever, sending force toward the cogwheels and chains and propelling the train. But the wheels had changed to a different direction, owing to the operation of the reverse gear device.

Clank... Clank... Clank...! The giant train began to travel backward, and Lloyd's mouth curved into a bright smile.

Good. It’s moving well.

Suddenly, Lloyd thought back to the day he had commissioned the test mule train to Corgidus, a relatively straightforward project considering the train could be converted from a carriage. There was only one complex component in the job.

The problem was this geared device.

For the switchback system to function properly, the train needed to travel forward and backward. But Lloyd knew very little about this apparatus.

But I had faith that Corgidus could pull it off since he's a master of mechanical development. He is among the top five across the entire continent when it comes to this skill.

Lloyd was confident that Corgidus could develop a gear if he gave a precise explanation of its broader purpose. The latter exceeded his expectations threefold.

"Wahaha. Brat, all you need is to change the force direction of the drive shaft based on the lever movement. Did you think I couldn't make a simple toy like this?"

Corgidus was also responsible for the changing railway that the sand men had just maneuvered. It was thanks to him that the switchback system could function smoothly.

Clack... Clank! The train smoothly passed the switch and then moved onto the new track, slowly ascending until it arrived at the second switchback section, where it stopped.

Lloyd then shouted, "Sand men! It's time for cardio!"

The sand men then dashed up to operate the switch, which led the train to a route above it. Once the railway successfully changed directions, Lloyd shifted the leveler into forward gear.

"Chug chug!"

The train then continued at a steady speed until it reached the third switchback. This process would repeat through a total of 21 zig zags until the train slowly conquered the steep slope of the mountains, moving from one direction to another. Javier, who was watching the whole thing, clucked his tongue.

This is unbelievable...

Even though Javier had anticipated this given the design of the tracks, he was still awestruck by Lloyd's foresight now that he was actually onboard the train.

"Young Master, please tell me you did not plan this from the start," Javier said.

"What do you mean this? The switchback system?"

"Yes." Javier gave a nod. "I mean from the start, exactly as I said."

"You mean going to the heavens to bait the Minister of Angels?" asked Lloyd.

"Yes, Young Master."

"If that's the case, yes. You're right."

"..."

"It's the truth," replied Lloyd. "I planned to start this construction from then. I figured this mountain would be the easiest way to set off the Magentano House and the queen. That's why I thought there was a good possibility."

"Possibly for what?"

"Well, nothing really special. Just stuff like how my construction offer would be accepted and I would end the project in success by using the switchback system. Of course, plans do not always go as expected, so I had a plan B and C in case something went wrong."

Nothing? This was nothing? Javier was overcome with the desire to tell Lloyd outright that he was a man with a monstrous ability to make predictions and plans. The knight wondered what kind of mindset was needed to execute such large-scale plans as if it were nothing. Simply put, it only seemed possible for someone who lived a completely different life from him.

And so, Javier couldn’t help but ask, “So, once you are done with the test, you will construct the railway over the range that will descend downward. Do you also have a plan for what comes after the construction?”

“Of course. It won’t be enough to just complete the construction.”

Clank! After forcefully pushing the forward gear, Lloyd grinned widely and brazenly stated, “I’m planning to extort a few things from the Benetto Kingdom that stands just beyond the range.”

***

In the meantime, the Benetto Kingdom’s palace was motionless from top to bottom from the effect of the Time Freeze skill. The walls, floors, and ceilings, the flags waving in the breeze, the officials, the supreme commander, and the king were all frozen in place. Now, after eleven months, a change started to take place.

Crack... Crack!

The frigidity energy that had stilled time and space started to lessen until it completely vanished. The world’s temperature returned to normal, and everything started to move back to life like a video that was unpaused. The people inside the palace began to move, the supreme commander took a few steps back, the flag on the terrace fluttered, and the king let out the rest of his sigh.

“Grant us the strength to overcome this disaster,” King Benettogna fervently pleaded, clinging to the sliver of hope he was left with.

I pray the supreme commander’s plan will work.

If not, the kingdom was doomed. The Bone Dragon, which belonged to the Magentano Kingdom, had already destroyed two peaks as part of its demonstration of power. It was a clear sign that the neighboring kingdom was going to launch a devastating attack.

If we choose direct combat, my men will be massacred by Magentano forces before we even get an opportunity to fight. Siege warfare would also be a bad decision since the Bone Dragon could simply smash through the gates and walls of the palace.

Therefore, the only viable strategy was to launch a large-scale ambush when their opponents were in a state of exhaustion from hiking through the harsh mountain range. That was the only way they could succeed.

That is how we will weaken the enemy's spirit, and in the meantime, I will hasten to gather support from neighboring countries to boost my chances of protecting my land.

His goal was to lower their morale. However, there was still the Bone Dragon, a fearsome foe, for him to deal with.

We will be able to deal with the dragon if we work together. No, we must deal with it and win no matter what.

However, the first task ahead of him was to kill the spirit of the Magentano army.

Please. King Benettogna repeatedly prayed to his kingdom's past predecessors and even toward the Pantata Range, pleading for strength. *I implore Pantalasa, the elemental king who assisted in the establishment of my kingdom, to punish the intruders with the harsh mountain terrain and blizzards. Please, let those vicious and inhumane monsters never set foot in this beautiful land.*

Despite the loss of two peaks, the monarch opted to place his trust in the Pantara Range and its ability to act as a natural shield.

Since the range lacks any proper pathways, the Magentano bastards will pay a hefty price for looking down on nature.

This king, on the other hand, was unaware of the reality he was in. He was unaware of the events that occurred while he was in a frozen state, such as how a madman had become the elemental king of the range and expanded

the rifts of the mountains before installing a sleek railway that could be easily traveled with a train. He was unaware that the railway had been completed just moments ago. The king knew nothing.

And his ignorance was understandable: all of these events had occurred while the world had come to a halt. From this king's perspective, the loss of the peaks was a recent event, similar to how a patient never feels anything during surgery and finds it over only after they open their eyes.

There was another terrifying fact that the king was completely unaware of as he prayed to his kingdom’s past monarchs and Pantalasa. At this exact moment, Lloyd, the man behind this predicament, was making his way to the Benetto Kingdom on the back of the Bone Dragon.

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Chapter 354: Lie With Confidence (1)

Fwoosh! Whoosh! Draggy's massive wings flapped in the air, causing a gust of wind to sweep across the Pantara Range. Lloyd, whose hair flowed against the wind, raised his head.

"The weather is fantastic," expressed Lloyd.

Lloyd didn't remember the last time he felt the warmth of the sunlight. It felt like the cells on his face, neck, and the rest of his exposed skin were dancing in joy.

Has it been about eleven months?

There had been one problem during the last eleven months of Time Freeze skill. It was that the Pantara Range nearly blocked the entire sun.

"We haven't been able to do anything close to bathing in the sun except for the time we constructed the railway going downward, right?"

"That is right." Javier's slight smile showed that he was also enjoying the sun. "But even then, there had to be clouds in the southern sky that we did not get to enjoy the sun very well. Someone stopped time in an untimely manner, Young Master."

"Hmm, so are you saying this is my fault? That everyone became as pale as a ghost due to the lack of sunlight?"

"What a perfect summary of my words. I am glad my point was clear, Young Master."

"You have not been willing to lose a single fight with me these days," pointed Lloyd.

"That is not true."

"What is then?"

“There was never a time I lost.”

“...”

“By the way, Master Lloyd,” said Javier, changing the subject.

“Yeah.”

“Are you sure riding on top of Sir Draggy is a good idea?” Javier's small smile vanished, replaced by a worried expression. “The Benetto Kingdom will be frightened by Sir Draggy’s sudden appearance.”

“They probably will be, right?”

“Yes, they will.”

“So, your concern is that... riding Draggy into their territory without any prior consultation or announcement could spark international conflict, right?”

“This time again, your summary is spot on.” Javier looked at Lloyd, puzzled as to why Lloyd chose this mode of transportation despite knowing so well.

Lloyd brushed his hair back and chuckled. “Well, there are lots of reasons, but if I have to pick one... Because we can.”

“What do you mean, Master Lloyd?”

“They simply lack the capabilities to hurt us in the first place, and they will not be ready for Draggy either.”

“But—”

“I understand what you mean,” Lloyd said, cutting him off. “It may not be right diplomatically. It could also invite protest from the Benetto Kingdom and neighboring countries, and it could even be a rash act that builds tension and hostility against our kingdom if I act poorly.”

“Does that mean you will act decently?”

“Duh,” said Lloyd, shrugging his shoulders and gazing at the Benetto Kingdom’s capital, which was a tiny dot. “I thought of making a modest and prudent visit to that place. Just the two of us without Draggy. But I decided I didn’t want to.”

“Why, Young Master?”

“I could not be bothered. And it was a hassle.” Lloyd grinned. “Just imagine what would happen if we went without Draggy. They will do a thorough check of our status and complain that we did not notify them in advance. And demand an explanation as to why we demolished the peaks and the meaning behind it and if it was an intention of invasion and whether the queen sent us here... Total hassle.”

“But—”

“Sure, that’s the protocol, but I can’t be bothered, and it is a waste of time. I mean, we have got a good method that would eliminate all of those tedious processes,” Lloyd said as he patted Draggy.

“To summarize, Young Master, you opted for this drastic method to skip every unnecessary and tedious process and save time,” Javier said with a sneer as if he couldn’t believe Lloyd.

“Yeah.”

“But, Master Lloyd, this could harm the Magentano House and the queen —”

“Nah. It’s all right. That king’s going be happier once we’re done.”

“Young Master?”

“All thanks to Draggy.”

“I do not get what you mean...”

“Well, watch if you’re curious. We’re here. Gear up.” Lloyd smiled like a sneaky kid.

Now the once-tiny dot that was the capital of the Benetto Kingdom had expanded into the size of a shield, and Javier could hear with his grandmaster senses what was happening down there.

“I-It’s the Bone Dragon!”

“Invasion!”

“Mother!”

“Come over here! Now! Hide!”

Javier heard people screaming hysterically in different parts of the capital. Some were pointing up at the sky, while others were screaming at the top of their lungs to warn of the approaching danger. Women were running to hide, babies were crying in their mothers’ arms, guards were moving around, their armor clacking, bells were announcing the approaching danger, and objects were thumping and thudding as they fell to the ground.

As Javier felt himself transform into a villain, a sting of remorse coursed through him. He then glanced over at Lloyd, who appeared perfectly fine.

“Hmm, just perfect. Since the people escaped on their own already, it’s easier for us to land.”

Javier couldn’t believe it. *Lloyd is enjoying the fact that the plaza is now empty!*

Dammit, Javier thought as he tightened his fist, wishing he could hit that chestnut-shaped back of the head just once. Meanwhile, Draggy attempted to make a soft landing on the ground.

Booom!

Even though he landed as softly as possible, Draggy still produced blood-curdling noise and vibration, and five rows of flowers were flattened under

its feet.

Lloyd, on the other hand, did not care in the slightest about the management's blood, sweat, and tears. He instead ran his eyes over the length of the plaza from Draggy's head before loading his mana into his voice. "Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera County, has arrived at the invitation of the House of Benetto and wishes to be granted the audience with King Benettogna."

The mana allowed his voice to travel far and wide, and it pierced into the ears of the crowd. Everyone cocked their heads.

What? He has been invited by the imperial family?

He and the Bone Dragon?

Um... Did that really happen?

I have not heard about this...

The news surprised the trembling young man, peeking lady, and shivering old man, as well as the rushing crossbow archers.

Hahaha. Look at their faces.

Lloyd grinned. What he had just said was a ruse. A blatant lie. The House of Benetto had never sent him an invitation for any kind of meet-up, but Lloyd did not hesitate to lie to their faces. Why? Simple.

This would make things easier later on.

Lloyd was certain that the king and his house would be thrilled by the end of the conversation and would eagerly volunteer to operate the range railway as a partner. He looked around the plaza.

"I tell you once again. I am here at the invitation of your rightful king. But the absence of preparation to welcome the guest prompts me to wonder if I got the date wrong. If anyone is willing, please kindly relay the message about my arrival to the king."

Lloyd's voice dripped with shamelessness as if he were spitting nothing but facts, and his demeanor was polite as well as shameless. Its effect was felt immediately.

“S-Stop!” yelled a capital defense officer leading the troops to the plaza, and 200 soldiers came to a halt, as did 180 crossbow archers, 300 spear soldiers, and the lancers who were harnessing their horses, who all received the halt order from their commanders as one thought dominated their minds.

If what that man said is true... Then it’s not an invasion!

That man Lloyd Frontera on the Bone Dragon said loud and clear that he was here invited to speak with the king and that someone should notify the king of his arrival, so there was only one conclusion based on the given information.

We don’t have to fight against the Bone Dragon!

Everyone smiled in relief. Their bodies suddenly relaxed. To be honest, they were genuinely terrified. The chances of taking down the Bone Dragon seemed extremely low despite their strong military presence. The same thing went among the officers, who valued their lives regardless of patriotism. Everyone was glad to know that the visitor was not an invader but a guest without any intention to fight. From then on...

“You! Over there!”

Each officer summoned the fastest soldier in his unit and issued the most urgent and desperate order of their lives: “Get to the palace right now and report what you have heard. Now!”

“Y-Yes!”

Soldiers rushed to the palace and shared the message with King Benettogna.

“What did you say? I invited him?”

“That is what he is claiming, Your Majesty.”

King Benettogna became confused and shut his mouth. He thought the Bone Dragon was here to burn everything down.

What is he thinking? Why is he saying that I have invited him?

He knew he had not invited that man from the Magentano Kingdom nor promised any talks, and he did not forget that the Bone Dragon had provoked his kingdom a few days ago by smashing two peaks of the Pantara Range.

Grit! King Benettona clenched his teeth, but instead of expressing his rage, he smiled naturally and said, “Ahaha. I never expected him to accept it this way.”

“Sire? Do you mean that the man and the Bone Dragon have been invited here to talk with you?”

“Indeed,” replied King Benettogna to the supreme commander, who looked baffled. “I considered how damaging it would be for us if we had a confrontation with the Magentano forces. Even if we win, the damage will be devastating.”

“You are certainly right, Your Majesty. Does that mean that you sent a letter without my knowledge to the House of Magentano to avoid a clash and any damage to our relationship?”

“I did truly. I am sorry for doing so behind your back, but I did not have another choice. In politics, there are times when it is even necessary to fool your allies.”

“I am simply overwhelmed by your wisdom, Your Majesty.”

“Haha. I am glad you see it that way.”

The king congratulated himself on his natural acting, which won over the supreme commander. The fact that he won over the commander was very important.

I must dance to Lloyd Frontera's tune and play along despite his ridiculous lie. That is how I can avoid an immediate clash.

With the Bone Dragon having just arrived in the capital, he was aware that they might not face a good outcome if they chose to reject conversation and engage in confrontation.

"Well then, let us move now. Let us hear what response the man has brought from the Magentano Kingdom," the king said as he rose, flashing the most relaxed smile he could muster. It was time to sound out Lloyd Frontera and find out why the latter barged in here with the Bone Dragon.

*I wonder what trickery he is up to now.*Unaware that this would be a day remembered throughout history in the future, King Benettogna, who was half-worried and terrified, resolvedly made his way to the plaza.

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Chapter 355: Lie With Confidence (2)

It had been nineteen years since King Benettogna had ascended to the throne, and he collected a wealth of knowledge from both his loyal and groveling subjects. Therefore, he only needed a few seconds to see right through a person. His wise eyes could clearly see through a person's character and their values. He was certain that this would be true today as well.

Whew...

As he entered the plaza, King Benettogna's eyes shone with determination, eager to meet the stranger despite the supreme commander's disapproval, the latter saying it was too dangerous for him to go alone. However, King Benettogna said everything was fine.

There's nowhere safe in my kingdom since the Bone Dragon is here.

As such, he had to deal with the unwelcome visitor himself and put an end to this situation. He cast a bright gaze toward the center plaza, where he saw the Bone Dragon with an oppressive energy exuding out of him and a young man standing beside his foot.

Lloyd Frontera. I heard he is a young noble who has become the center of attention in Magentano. He is also the meritorious retainer of Queen Magentano.

Despite the natural barrier created by the Pantara Range, rumors spread like wildfire in his kingdom due to their proximity to the Magentano Kingdom's border. This was especially true when the stories were about an extraordinary figure from a potential enemy kingdom.

Rumors say he has countless heroic achievements, beginning with saving people in the east from disaster.

And the moment he laid eyes on Lloyd, he understood why there were so many rumors about him: he was extremely handsome.

Haha, so a human can be this beautiful. How could a person be so blinding? The rumors merely said that he was all right in terms of appearance, failing to elaborate on his dashing looks.

Perhaps the Magentano Kingdom had different beauty standards? King Benettogna made his way, admiring the beauty that the people in the neighboring kingdom seemed to take for granted. He opened his arms wide to make the impression on the nearby crowd that this meeting had been planned in advance.

With a bright smile, he said, “Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera family. I have heard about your reputation. I am beyond happy to meet you in real life.”

The young noble that the king greeted turned around, his silver curls spinning with him, crinkled his fine brows and said, “I am honored to meet King Benettogna, the rightful lord of the land. I am Javier Asrahan, a knight.” Javier’s introduction shocked King Benettogna.

“Hmm?” He gaped in disbelief. This man was the knight, Javier Asrahan? This noble and gorgeous young man?

Hold on. Then, who is Lloyd Frontera?

The young man, who looked like an ugly potato in comparison to the knight standing next to him, bowed as that thought entered the king’s mind. He then spoke, “I am Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera family, at your service. I am infinitely honored to be in your presence, Your Majesty.”

King Benettogna suddenly felt a shaft of shock and cocked his head to the side, looking at Javier and Lloyd each. That was when he finally realized he had made a mistake.

My. I made a mistake.

He could not believe it. He mistook the silver-haired knight for Lloyd because of his elegant face, and he mistook the real Lloyd for a peasant because of his potato-like face.

“Ehem. Hmm! Ehem!” The king cleared his throat.

The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose with remorse. “It is all right. This has happened to me many times. But thank you for accepting my abrupt request for a meeting.”

“Thank you? I doubt it.” As soon as he came close enough to lower his voice, his friendly public demeanor vanished, and a sharp look appeared on his face. “What is your plan, and what malicious scheme does your queen have in mind for you to come here?”

The king’s eyes were filled with doubt. Lloyd and the Bone Dragon were uninvited guests, and this talk wasn’t in the schedule. “Do you and your queen plan to threaten us?” There was tension in his voice since this moment marked a critical point. If the talk went well, it meant an increase in his political influence. But something else had to be done first, which was finding out the real intention behind Lloyd's outrageous arrival with the Bone Dragon.

“I am here to notify you, not threaten you,” Lloyd said without pulling any punches. The king’s brows lifted almost up to his fading hairline, so Lloyd added, “I mean what I say. And it is a notification. Not a threat.”

“Notify me? But about what?” replied the king, wondering what it could be about. Demand for surrender? Hand over the territory? His heart thumped in nervousness.

Lloyd shrugged to indicate that it wasn’t anything serious. “That a trade route has been opened.”

“A trade route?”

“Yes,” replied Lloyd.

“What trade route?”

“I am talking about the trade route that connects the Magentano Kingdom to yours.”

“There is no such a thing.” King Benettogna frowned deeply. He couldn’t wrap around what this young man was talking about.

My kingdom is surrounded by lands, and the only trade route, if there is one, must be through the Pantara Range, which is why trade with Magentano is only possible by crossing another kingdom. What is this man saying?

A road had to be paved in the Pantara Range for a trade route to be opened. However, the task was impossible, has been impossible, and will remain impossible in the future.

Perhaps, he is speaking metaphorically?

The king wondered what that could mean. His head was spinning as he tried to find an answer.

That put a smile on Lloyd’s face. “There is no other meaning to my words, Sire. A direct trade route has been paved between my kingdom and yours.”

“...”

“I am being truthful.”

“Do you mean in the Pantara Range?”

“That is exactly right,” affirmed Lloyd. “I had the Bone Dragon demolish two peaks, widened the rifts, and flattened the slopes as you may be somewhat aware. And so, we laid a railway on the range.”

“A railway?”

“Yes, a railway that allows a train to travel over the Pantara Range twice a day.”

“Railway? Train?”

“You could think of it as a metal road that moves through a series of connected carriages.”

King Benettogna stared intensely at Lloyd, who was speaking very confidently. He wondered if this young man had lost his mind and how he must react to that strange and illogical drivel. Every word that Lloyd said was met with skepticism, but not so much because of the concept behind the train and railway, which seemed plausible. It was the construction of such a road in the Pantara Range that he had a hard time believing.

“Why do you come to my kingdom and spout lies?” His voice now grew stern. “Is this you and your queen’s way of humiliating and mocking me and my family?”

“Hmm... Is that how my words sounded in your ears?” asked Lloyd.

“Indeed.”

Clench! “A metal road that allows travel across the Pantara Range? That means you were able to complete a large-scale construction in those rugged mountain terrains. Are you telling me that such a project was completed in just a matter of days?” gritted out King Benettogna.

The king’s frustration grew with each word out of Lloyd’s mouth. The entire project seemed impossible for him as he was unaware of the Time Freeze skill, which had been in effect for several months. From his perspective, the destruction of the peaks occurred a few days ago. He didn’t trust Lloyd’s words that the metal road had been built through the range and saw it as a ruse to trick him.

“I will ask you one question,” he said, engulfed by doubt and anger. “What do you hope to gain by humiliating me? Are you attempting to make an example of me and send a warning to neighboring countries?”

Lloyd understood where the king was coming from. The Magentano Kingdom was a political powerhouse, and Queen Magentano, who was also a rare sword master, led it very well. There was no civil war in the kingdom, and the land was fertile. Tens of thousands of well-trained elite forces worked directly for her, and Javier Asrahan and the Bone Dragon made them even stronger, which was a nightmare for the countries around it. Just like that, the Magentano enjoyed hegemony like never before, and it

owned the capacity to wage wars and wipe out the land as it liked. This was how King Benettogna perceived the Magentano Kingdom.

“I believe this is the reason you see me and my imperial family as nothing more than a pebble on the street. To create a precedent through your carnage and undermine the confidence of the neighboring nations with your heinous accomplishments, eventually establishing an empire. Am I wrong?” His voice faltered, and the world appeared to darken. He went on to believe that there were only two possible outcomes from this situation: Either resist and perish here or submit and become a puppet king. He was not even certain that he would have a choice.

The moment the Bone Dragon landed here, the answer was set.

King Benettogna exhaled a deep sigh. And he resolved to himself. If this pawn of the Magentano bared its teeth and relayed a threat from him to its master...

I shall have to save my soldiers and people, even at the risk of my own life.

That was his duty, he thought, the duty that would make his predecessors proud.

“Hmm, um. I did expect you to act this way... But I guess my words do not really hold value to you at this moment, no?” Lloyd chuckled in embarrassment as the king solidified his misunderstood resolution.

The king’s brows lifted again.

“I am truly sorry,” Lloyd continued, “It was my mistake to think you would easily trust me. It would have been better to show you from the start, as seeing is believing.”

“What are you-”

Before being given any chance to finish his sentence, Lloyd instantly reached out for the former’s hand. *Grab!*

“Shh. Excuse me for a second.”

A small amount of mana then entered the king, dominating his entire body like invasive troops. His throat tightened to the point where no sound came out of it, and he became greatly dismayed. However, just as he was about to ask the supreme commander for assistance through bodily gestures, Lloyd yelled aloud, “Okay, rightful lord of this land, as per your request, I shall show you the train built in the Pantara Range!”

Lloyd then yanked the king’s arm after he finished, and the movement was so natural that it appeared as if the king was being led to hop on the Bone Dragon’s hands.

“Okay, Draggy!” called Lloyd. “Time to show the king the rift train!”

Fwish! Draggy leaped into the air, clutching Lloyd, Javier, and King Benettogna in his hands, causing the supreme commander and guard commander waiting for their king's cue to hiccup in surprise.

They began hiccupping as they gazed at the distant sky, their king fading away, and this was the first time in history that their king had been abducted.

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Chapter 356: About After-Sales Service (1)

Fwoosh! King Benettogna clenched his fists to keep from wetting himself in fear as the Bone Dragon's enormous torso soared into the sky.

“Eek..!”

His only intention was to save his kingdom from the brink of disaster and have a discussion with the madman who invaded his land with the Bone Dragon. It never crossed the king’s mind that he would glide through the air on the Bone Dragon’s hand.

Ha! Eek! Ack!

Fwoosh! Whoosh! Fwang! Swoosh! As Draggy fanned his wings and sped forward, the headwind slapped against the king’s face and the rest of his body. His shoulder shrank in fear. He desperately prayed not to fall on the ground, braced his shaky legs, and struggled to uphold his remaining pride and authority as a king.

“Wh-What! What! Eek! What are you doing?!”

The monarch yelled at the top of his lungs, hoping his voice wasn’t shaking. He did not duck down or lower his body, proceeding to stand up tall with pride instead. Even at the risk of his own life, he was determined to appear strong. It was Lloyd who was taken aback by this sight.

“Ugh! Come on!” Lloyd reached out and grasped the king's shoulders, preventing him from freefalling out of the sky. “Please forgive me for kidnapping you in this manner! But there seemed to be no other way to convince you!”

“Convince me?”

“I mean the construction of the rift railroad in the Pantara Range! If you can’t believe me, I will show you!”

“Show me? Are you still stuck on that nonsense?”

“I’m trying to prove that I’m not talking nonsense! So, please! Duck down for a bit!”

“Eek!”

Lloyd’s tight hold crushed his shoulder, causing him to lower his posture The king became furious, and his beard trembled in irritation. He was about to shout at Lloyd, but it was the latter who spoke first.

“Um, do you see that over there?” Lloyd said as he pointed somewhere.

“…What?” The king missed his chance to go on a rage.

Lloyd took advantage of his confusion by quickly pointing in one direction and tempting him to turn around, “You will understand all my actions if you look over there.”

“What now?” the king observed, half-dazed and half-doubtful. His eyes followed Lloyd’s fingers until they were looking down on the Pantara Range. He let out a gasp without realizing it. The peaks and rifts that used to exist below them had been neatly trimmed down and tidied. Of course, the land was still full of steep slopes in any case. But… “Huh? What is that?”

There were zigzag lines along the mountain slopes. Upon a closer look, it appears that the lines weren’t merely markings on the ground. They were elevated roads with two metal bars running directly parallel to each other. Not only that, a large and long coach that he had never seen before was clunking its way uphill on one part of it, following the two metal bars.

“This is the railroad and train I mentioned before,” Lloyd clarified as the sides of his mouth turned upward. As expected, it was the right move to run the test mule, so it would come at the perfect time. Thinking that to himself, he glanced at the king and continued speaking, “The idea is simple. It’s to place two metal tracks at an equal distance from each other and make a train with precisely sized wheels run along them.”

“But what about the slope-”

“Well, the project utilized various techniques. But they are a trade secret, so I can’t tell you more.”

The king became gravely silent.

Meanwhile, Lloyd’s voice became more serious. “First, please forgive me for behaving in such an impertinent manner to you, the rightful ruler of the Benetto Kingdom. I only caused such trouble for fear that our conversation would draw out and the atmosphere would turn hostile. Regardless of my intentions, the reckless way I brought you here deserves reproach without a single doubt.”

“...”

“I thought it would be best to let you confirm my words with your own two eyes, even if it meant taking slightly offensive measures. It was the most effective way to avoid damaging our relationship with unnecessary misunderstandings and the resulting disputes.”

“...”

“I know this is just another excuse, but please forgive my rudeness with your boundless mercy,” Lloyd said, his voice somber and sincere.

Of course, that doesn’t change the fact that I abducted the king. I myself wondered if I went a little overboard this time.

Lloyd had hesitated. However, he ultimately chose to proceed with the method as it was obvious he would waste far too much time and energy otherwise.

For them, Draggy was demolishing the peaks just a few days ago because of the different perceptions of time caused by my skill. They obviously wouldn’t believe that I’ve built a railroad across the range.

He would have had to invest an enormous amount of effort to persuade them of the entire affair. Given how tense Draggy had made them, it

seemed doubtful that anything positive would come of it. This was why Lloyd decided to just show the king. You have to see it to believe it, right?

And now, it's my turn to appease him. I was honestly a little rude.

All the blood drained from his face, the king was still as pale as a sheet. Feeling guilty for shocking him with a kidnapping, Lloyd removed his winter clothes and carefully placed them over the king's shoulders. Instead of saying anything, he remained silent and waited for the king to respond.

King Benettogna's full, white beard twitched in surprise. He didn't expect Lloyd to apologize.

Did he just apologize to me?

It was rather out of the ordinary. He had assumed that, having been captured helplessly, he would be killed in his defenseless state. Instead, he was given an earnest apology from his captor, who had the most genuine and kind look in his eyes. At the same time, he was showing him there was a railroad that crossed the Pantara Range as evidence for why he was left with no other choice.

Does that mean this fellow was telling the truth?

Of course, it could be a trick to make him lower his guard. No, that was more than likely the case. But the monarch shook his head in the end after much thought.

No. There's no need for him to use such a trick when he has the upper hand. Right now, I am nothing but a weak, old man that has been kidnapped by them. They could easily harm me if they wanted to.

Yet, Lloyd Frontera did not harm, threaten, or intimidate him in any way. He calmly showed him proof of the claim he made earlier. And now, he was politely and cautiously asking for his forgiveness with a sincere apology.

If he wanted to take my life, he wouldn't have to apologize. He could just finish me off right here. The same is true for my kingdom.

If that man’s goal had been to destroy the Benetto Kingdom, he wouldn’t need such an elaborate plan. Lloyd could simply take his life, charge into the capital, and make the Bone Dragone lead a destructive and bloody massacre. Without the king’s leadership, the kingdom’s defensive forces would have been rendered useless.

But he isn’t doing that.

At this point, King Benettogna finally lowered his suspicion to a certain extent but was still displeased about being kidnapped. With a gaze reflecting his remaining doubts, he sourly threw a question at Lloyd, “What a terrible character you possess. Let me ask you a question then. Lloyd Frontera, is this how you always are?”

“Oh, no, it is not.”

“Then?”

“I am slightly more terrible and vicious than this on average.”

“...”

“Ah, I’m sorry. That wasn’t a threat. I didn’t mean it to sound that way. Sincerely.”

That just now did sound like a threat, thought King Benettogna as he licked his bitter lips. And then he realized...

I’ve been on the losing side of this negotiation from the very start.

In any case, Lloyd had a huge advantage in this negotiation and was backed by the hegemony of the Magentano Kingdom. So the king knew he should be grateful that he wasn’t harmed and his kingdom wasn’t invaded. However, he felt like he was receiving a notice from the Magentano Kingdom rather than engaging in a negotiation with them.

“Then, let me hear it.” The king responded, his expression betraying his attempt to conceal his sorrow. The situation was a little humiliating, but he had no other choice.

“The will of my queen?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes. That seems to be the place for that.”

“Thank you for your generosity.”

“I should be the one to express gratitude. That is, to the House of Magentano for choosing not to invade us.” The king joked with a smile, though the words he said seemed sincere.

Lloyd spoke more courteously and said, “I understand. I will then convey the message from Her Majesty. Queen Alicia Termina Magentano desires to directly engage in trade and commerce with your kingdom.”

“Trade? Commerce?”

“Yes,” Lloyd said, “As you should know, the Magentano Kingdom has always wanted to pave a path toward the southwest region. However, we couldn’t seem to overcome the tough natural barrier formed by the mountains, and our attempts were thwarted.”

“Yes. The Pantara Range.”

Lloyd agreed, saying, “In light of this, my queen has specifically ordered me to build a trade route that enables safe passage over the Pantara Range.”

“Can’t it possibly be a route for invasion?”

“Sire, the fate of the railroad down there is in your hands. Whether it is for trade or invasion is entirely up to you,” explained Lloyd calmly.

“Are you implying that you just fulfilled your responsibility to open a path and that politics will determine how it’s used? That is irresponsible.”

“I’m sorry. But that’s the truth.”

“Yes, that is true. I will not deny it.”

“Thank you for your understanding.”

“Do not be.” King Benettogna clicked his tongue. The more this conversation dragged on, the more despicable and desirable he found Lloyd Frontera. From his subtle way of dodging responsibility to his brazen yet calm attitude, the king noticed it all. He was annoyed that Lloyd was his opponent on the negotiation table and wondered what it would have been like if he had him under his command.

I am envious. I never expected that a day would come when I would grow jealous of that greedy and ferocious woman, Alicia.

Lloyd, who was not hesitant to cross any lines to gain an advantage and use it to steer a negotiation, made the king jealous of her. His tactic put them both in a position where they had to play the game that he had set up. At the same time, he was also astute enough to play it safe and avoid harming his opponent as much as possible.

“You are not trying to push the political responsibility to an old man like me with your sweet talk, are you?” the king asked, sounding Lloyd out and subtly demanding to know what he would gain by agreeing to the deal. Sure, he wasn’t in a position to make demands. However, he still had to test the man’s sincerity in the latter’s suggestion for partnership. His wrinkled eyes shined with curiosity and anticipation as he waited to see if Lloyd would respond to his prodding.

Lloyd grinned broadly as if he had come prepared to provide the monarch with exactly what he was looking for. “Of course.”

“Of course?”

“Yes,” Lloyd answered as if he were a salesman skillfully satisfying every need of his customer. “After-sales service is a necessary step after a successful transaction.” This was the golden rule of business, as it allowed companies to extract the maximum amount of value from their clients. Lloyd then flashed a radiant smile filled with kindness, generosity, and his dreams of exploitation.

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Chapter 357: About After-Sales Service (2)

In Korea, the service provided after a sale was known as “A/S Service.” It extended beyond the sale of automobiles, refrigerators, TVs, etc., and included financing, insurance, cafés, and neighborhood establishments. In short, it included almost all transactions.

The goal of sales is to satisfy consumers and do all in its power to entice them to purchase products. So, the purpose of after-sales service is to ensure that customers will not make purchases from competitors.

The after-sales service was the bait to keep consumers loyal to the firm. It was meant to trap them in and suck them dry. That was the basis of after-sales service. The two went together like salt and light, alpha and omega, or pasta and marinara.

That is why it’s popular for even local cafés to offer discounts like a coupon for a free drink after purchasing ten drinks or restaurants to provide complimentary candy and coffee after a meal. In a nutshell, this is also a similar kind of after-sales service.

Lloyd thought that to himself and turned to see King Benettogna’s somewhat balded forehead. He was enjoying the excitement of the ride. The king’s white beard danced in the wind, and his eyes gleamed even more brightly than his glossy, bald forehead. The king no longer trembled in worry or dread.

Well. It looks like he’s happy with the first part of my service.

They had resolved their misunderstanding over the railroad earlier, and the king’s animosity had lessened now in response to Lloyd’s sincere apologies. So Lloyd was offering this ride to him as a service.

I still have a lot to exploit out of him. It’d be a waste to stop here after clarifying a few misunderstandings and dispelling his hostility toward me.

Since they were now on good terms, Lloyd wanted to take things one step further and gain the king's favor, which is why he was offering the "Draggy Ride" service to him. Lloyd stood to lose nothing from the arrangement since he needed to bring the king back to the kingdom in any case. However, he presented the service as a gesture of sincere kindness and made sure the king thought it was something special. That was the truth behind Lloyd's service to the king. But he didn't stop there.

"Your Majesty, are you enjoying the flight experience?"

"Hahaha. It's nice, very nice. I never expected I would get this sort of experience in my final leg of life. This is my first time getting a full view of my land and people like this."

"Then, may I ask for a favor?"

"A favor?"

"It is nothing major, but I was wondering if you could directly tell your people about the trade route in the range once we return to the capital."

"Hahaha. Are you sure about it?" asked the king with a smile, which seemed to say, "You cheeky bastard."

"As you are the legitimate ruler of the Benetto Kingdom," Lloyd shrugged as though there was no other choice. "The trade route in the range will be a turning point of the future of your kingdom. It's not appropriate for an outsider like me to make such an important announcement. It is only right for you, the kingdom's legitimate ruler, to do the job."

"I see. Do you mind if I also relay the message from your queen to my people?" asked the king.

"It would be an honor." Lloyd grinned.

King Benettogna cast a meaningful gaze at Lloyd. "You are quite a cunning person."

"I will not deny that, sire."

“Truly, I appreciate your frankness with me. I also noticed you are making an effort to uphold my dignity as a king and hold me to my word. Am I right?”

“You saw right through me.”

“Yes, but I understand why you are doing this. Nothing is free in this world.”

“Regardless, you will be satisfied in the end. I am sure,” said Lloyd.

“I wish I will.” A similar wry smile appeared on both of their faces.

Lloyd clicked his tongue inwardly. *Haah. The monarch here is also astute.* Thinking the man was truly fit to be a king, Lloyd stole a quick glance at him.

I planned to give the king a grand entrance to the kingdom on top of Draggy and make his presence appear more powerful. Then he would be persuaded to immediately declare the opening of the Pantara Range’s trade route and the start of a partnership with the House of Magentano. That would have allowed me to service him by strengthening his dignity as the king while holding him accountable for his words. He saw through my plans.

King Benettogna’s statements to his people were bound to carry a lot of weight, forcing him to make decisions that were steadfast to his promises. If he didn’t...

His words would lose credibility, trust, and power, which could mean he loses political impact on the global stage.

After that, he would be bound by his own words and obligated to continue working with the Magentano Kingdom as a trade partner.

Well, this kind of relationship will be beneficial for both of us.

This was undoubtedly not a loss for the Benetto Kingdom. When they got close to the capital, Lloyd securely gripped the king’s shoulder and said,

“We will descend now. Please be careful of the wind.”

Whoosh! Whoosh! Draggy went into descent mode and began fluttering his wings with a loud stirring noise. As his massive body slowed and made its way downward, the view of the capital began to change from the size of a ping-pong ball, a watermelon, a road intersection, to a baseball field. At last, Draggy landed on the plaza like how Bill Gates sings in Karaoke. Micro-softly.

Boom! The tremendous roar echoed across the square, and the vases crushed at the very first landing pulverized to dust. But Lloyd did not care in the slightest for the blood, sweat, and tears that someone put into them.

“Okay. It’s time for you to speak.”

“I see,” said the king.

Lloyd helped the king stand up on Draggy’s palm and took a step back. At the same time, he gestured to Draggy. *“Lift him up.”*

Clack! Understanding the message, Draggy smoothly raised his hand, making it into a podium at the center of the plaza. King Benetto stood in the middle of the dragon’s palm. There was more to Lloyd’s service.

“Hey, it’s your turn now.” Lloyd gestured to Javier, who immediately understood and took a step forward before placing his hand on the king’s shoulder.

Seeing the king flinch, Javier reassured him, “If you speak, I will amplify your voice, Your Majesty.”

“Is that doable?”

“Yes, to some degree.”

It was a simple process, made easier by the Asrahan Core Technique. Nodding, Javier injected a tiny quantity of mana into the king’s body, wrapping it around his voice chord.

“Ehem.”

Ehem...! Ehem! Ehem!

The sound of him innocently clearing his throat echoed across the surroundings of the square. Even the king was surprised by the magnified sound of his cough.

“It is all right. Please continue.”

Gaining comfort and confidence from Javier’s words, the king’s eyes became calmer as he ran them across the plaza.

Everyone, even the people frightened by the re-emergence of the Bone Dragon and the troops that raced to rescue the king, gazed at the king with unease.

The king spoke as if he was comforting them. “As you can see right now, I am safe, and the Bone Dragon respects me. I assure you. You have nothing to worry about.”

About..! About.. About...

His words echoed as he calmly continued his speech. The Bone Dragon had not come here to invade them. The Magentano Kingdom was a strong ally of theirs. He also shared how the Pantara Range trade route was built in secret before anyone took notice. All information about the project was kept confidential and restricted to him and the queen of Magentano as they were both concerned about interference from outside kingdoms if there was a leak. His speech was a mix of lies and truths.

“Therefore, from this day onward, the House of Benetto and the House of Magentano will become trade partners. I do not doubt that our partnership will bring greater prosperity to both houses.”

Houses! Houses... Houses...

As soon as the people understood what King Benettogna’s self-assured declaration meant, they let out an explosive shout of admiration and went

down on their knees, expressing their subordination, respect, and gratitude to their ruler proudly standing on top of the domineering Bone Dragon. The sight also caused the king's own heart to pound.

Whew.

Never in his wildest dreams did he imagine that his day would be so versatile and that he would get the opportunity to deliver a speech on Bone Dragon's hand.

I am becoming more and more jealous of the Bone Dragon. During my 19-year rule, I never once got them to obey me like this.

One Bone Dragon seemed to be more effective than a massive military display involving thousands of troops, and he was pleased with the responses of his people, as did Lloyd.

Hmm... Perfect. Just perfect.

Lloyd examined the crowd, pleased that he got his desired outcome from lending the Bone Dragon to King Benettogna.

And now, I'll squeeze him dry with the power of customer satisfaction.

Now that the king was content with Lloyd's service and bound by his own words, Lloyd wasted no time seizing this chance. He switched places with Javier and smiled like he was the salesman of the year.

Lloyd spoke in a voice dripping with integrity, honesty, and admiration, "That was excellent, sire. Your speech touched me."

The king cleared his throat. "Ehem! Hmm! Did it?"

"Yes, look at how my hands are shivering."

"Hahaha. All I did was walk on the carpet you set down."

"No, it takes real skill to make use of the carpet that's been set down."

“Hmm... I smell flattery.”

“Was I too obvious?”

“You were. I imagine you have a favor to ask?” asked King Benettogna.

“Was I that obvious, Your Majesty?”

“Do not beat around the bush. I am in the palm of your hands in any case,” the king said bitterly, knowing full well of his position. That trade route in the range could be turned into an enemy invasion route, so the decisionmaker here was the House of Magentano, particularly Lloyd Frontera, its messenger. “We should be thankful to you and the House of Magentano because you first offered your hand in friendship. I am not naive. I know that your kindness does not come for free. So, please tell me how much I owe you for today.”

The king knew. There were no free lunches in this world.

Thinking the same, Lloyd replied, “Since you ask, sire, I will give you an answer.”

Fwip!

Lloyd drew a couple of pieces of paper from his jacket. These were the contracts he had written before coming here. “The details of my requests are listed here. Please take a look,” he said.

King Benettogna was too astonished to respond, realizing what those documents were at first sight. Thanks to that, he also realized Lloyd had come with the determination to suck him dry.

Tsk.

King Benettogna opened the contracts, feeling like a honeybee trapped in a spider’s web. He was both outraged and relieved a few seconds later.

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Chapter 358: TAbout After-sales Service (3)

This is... Tsk.

When King Benettogna read the pact, he impulsively clicked his tongue, and two opposing feelings surged through his heart.

Haah. What should I make of this?

“I read the contract you gave me,” he said, his gaze sharpening as he alternated between feeling comforted and wanting to curse Lloyd out.

“Thank you.”

“In summary, the Frontera Family will receive 5% of the total trade value of the commerce facilitated by the Pantara Range as a maintenance fee.”

“That is on point, sire.” Lloyd grinned.

The king’s brows crumpled. “But maintenance fee? To me, it looks like an exploitative customs tax.”

“I have nothing to say if you feel it that way. As you know, it’s just a name for the expense.”

“Are you admitting that the fee is partly a customs tax?”

“I hope you will also acknowledge that, given its location on such rough terrain, maintaining the trade route will be extremely expensive,” defended Lloyd.

“Hmm.”

“Indeed,” Lloyd confirmed. “The constant blizzards will cover the railroad in snow and freeze it. There's also the water and icicles that will come down the slope and damage the roadbed. is more, the timber and gravel on the road will need to be cared for daily. That means the labor required for the

maintenance process will create an additional expense on top of the materials needed for it.”

“There is more...?”

“Of course. I built a small station at the peak as a resting area for people and shipments crossing the range. It also has a residence for the workers who will be maintaining the railroad. That facility will create more cost since it needs to be regularly serviced as well and have food, clothing, and other resources for the workers.”

“Do you mean that you will have me to pay for all of this?”

“Since I built the railroad after much toil, I would appreciate it if you considered it a fee for using the train; additionally, 5% of the total value of overall goods is comparatively nothing,” reminded Lloyd sharply.

“...”

“Am I wrong?”

“Tsk,” the king clucked his tongue. Everything Lloyd said was correct. This trade route would eventually allow him to trade directly with the Magentano Kingdom, an emerging superpower in the international order. The shipments that used to circle the range would now take this trade route instead. Moreover, that would be true for others outside the Benetto Kingdom.

There will be shipments from neighboring nations that travel through my territory before reaching the trade route on the range. I would be able to collect a considerable amount of customs tax from this.

The economic value of the trade route would be significantly larger than the tax itself. Therefore, 5% was a drop in the bucket compared to the total profit he would gain.

“How do you plan on receiving the fee?” asked King Benettogna.

“Oh, that should be written down below.”

“Hmm.”

“Over there. Slightly lower. Yes, that’s it.”

“The maintenance fee will be converted into gold coins... To be later collected every quarter?”

“Yes. It’ll be an easy task for the Bone Dragon to move around a few chests of the gold coin.”

King Benettogna made a face that said, “You came prepared.”

Lloyd nodded in understanding.

Of course. Of course, I came prepared.

It was truly an obvious statement. Considering the scale of the project, Lloyd wanted to get everything he could from it on top of the Tears of Summer.

Plus, it indeed costs money to maintain the tracks.

Lloyd planned to leave dozens of orc soldiers and a few elves, but when he estimated the costs of their food, living, and facility management materials, his heart sank.

All of it was my precious money!

Lloyd believed it would be unfair for others to benefit from the trade route that he used his own money to safely maintain and operate. So he spent the past few days calculating the cost of maintenance and how much he would need to be paid to make a good profit.

The answer was five percent. That covered the maintenance enough, and the remaining money would be used for my fiefdom.

That remaining money would serve as Lloyd’s lifetime pension and grow his nest egg.

I mean, I've got lots of money, thanks to the Dragon King Sponsorship. But you never know.

You never knew when or how your source of income would be cut. That was just the way of life. It was not uncommon for trusted banks to go bankrupt on a random day. Nothing was 100% reliable, including his sponsorship from the dragon king.

That sleepyhead dragon is surprisingly moody.

The way Lloyd saw it, Dragon King Verkis liked to act on a whim. He was a sluggard with a villainous temperament.

There's a chance that I may accidentally get on his bad side one day. I must have insurance in place.

Yes, the Dragon King's sponsorship was enormously significant, but it was unreliable money, and the rest of the various sources of income had their drawbacks.

Similarly, the queen can withdraw her support to our fiefdom at any time if I lose her favor. The other revenue I get from the Lacona Viscounty's tax and water bill is quite small.

As a result, any extra source of revenue, such as money from the Benetto Kingdom, would grow his nest egg even more.

It's perfect. Stable and abundant.

He had carefully calculated and planned for today. There was only one purpose for the kidnapping of the king and the services given to appease him afterward: to get this contract in front of the monarch.

Life is long, and money is always needed.

Repeating that motto in his head, Lloyd pointed to the bottom of the contract.

“As such, starting next quarter, all you need is to pay the amount in the contract for the next 50 years.”

“50 years...?” King Benettogna uttered in a daze.

“Yes, but the period is very short,” Lloyd responded as if it was obvious. “The trade route will last for over 500 years unless war or another natural disaster destroys it. That is how long you will continue to reap the benefits that come from it. Paying a fee for a mere 50 years is truly nothing compared to what you will get in return.”

“But if a war or natural disaster does-”

“I got that covered, too. Yes, there. Do you see it?”

King Benettogna sealed his lips. It was really there.

If a war, natural disaster... or another similar event causes the trade route to close... The maintenance fee will be temporarily suspended... Haah.

King Benettogna gave Lloyd a serious look. By this point, his dislike for the young man had vanished and been replaced by admiration for his detailed preparation.

A duration of 50 years is quite appropriate. It’s a long period but not excessively so. And given this boy’s age... Yes, he’s saying he wants to get his fair share from my kingdom just while he’s alive.

Even though Lloyd made his intentions blatantly clear, he didn’t cross any lines. He shrugged when the king stared at him intently.

I’m not sure whether to call him bold or brazen. He does what he needs to do.

Dumbstruck, a snort escaped him. The king nodded. “I see. I understand you.”

“That means...”

“I agree to your terms.”

“Thank you so much!” With that, Lloyd bowed 90 degrees and later brought out a pen and ink bottle at lightning speed.

“Haha... Now? You want me to sign the papers right now?”

“Yes, the rightful owner of Benetto Kingdom.”

“But the contract needs the king’s seal for my signature to have any effect. Why don’t we make our way to the palace?”

“Yes, I am overwhelmed with gratitude, but...” mumbled Lloyd hesitantly.

“But?”

“Being a coward, I am scared you will have a change of heart on our way to the palace.”

“Huh…?”

“How about signing the contract now and sealing it with your stamp later?”

“Tsk. You look like you are going to kidnap me again if I do not give my signature.”

“Please forgive me.”

“Ha... How brazen. You do not even deny my words.”

“Please forgive me for that, too, sire.”

“I see... Then give that to me.” He then seized the pen without hesitation and scrawled his name on the contract while looking at Lloyd. “There is something I am curious about now that I signed the contract.”

“Yes, sire.”

“Earlier, you said I would be asked to pay a maintenance fee starting next quarter. Why is that? Why not this quarter?”

“Oh, it’s a complimentary benefit.”

Once again, the king was at a loss of words. Just like that, they entered the palace and signed and put the king’s seal on the contracts. At last, Lloyd had secured his desired deal.

Great. Just perfect. I’m set for life!

Several strong emotions began to boil up in his heart. Although he still needed to stop the restoration of destiny, once that job was done, he would be set for life.

“Lloyd Frontera,” called the king. Lloyd noticed something off about that voice. “I have a question I would like to ask you.”

“Oh, yes. What is it?”

“Is there a lady you’ve promised to build a future with?”

Lloyd clamped his mouth shut. He instantly understood where this was going.

Oh, it’s been a while. Father-in-law attack.

Suppressing his wry smile, Lloyd said, “Please forgive me.”

“Hmm?”

“Could you be asking... because you have a daughter of marriageable age?”

“Haha? Did you read my mind?”

“No, but I had a guess.” That wry smile could no longer be suppressed. It rose upward. And his prediction turned out to be true. The king was entertaining the possibility of an arranged marriage for his daughter with

Lloyd. The reason for it was simple. Lloyd was spitefully cunning, and he expected him to become his kingdom's most reliable ally.

I am an excellent judge of character. This man is something. He may be sly and selfish to others. But he cares an awful lot for his own people.

The king was certain about this after seeing the construction site of the railroad earlier.

The work site was thoroughly equipped with safety measures, and the workers' quarters were considerable and robust, reflecting his treatment of his men. Furthermore, if a wedding took place, my son-in-law would be the Magentano House's meritorious retainer. That would be an incredible benefit.

He had multiple daughters and sending one of them to marry Lloyd would benefit her future and his kingdom. However, there was something the king overlooked in Lloyd: the latter possessed marriage ideals of the 21st century.

Ha. Marry someone without knowing what the person looks like? And with this fancy house? I'd be a madman if I took the deal. I would live the rest of my life in misery and exhaustion. I'm not enough of a madman to want that.

No matter what, he wanted to have a love marriage and lead a cozy life with someone who was not exceedingly high in status. He would be shackling himself if he married a princess of a royal family.

"Once again, please forgive me."

"Hmm... I don't believe this will be a disadvantageous move for you," ventured King Benettogna.

"The only thing I can offer is an apology. My apologies." With his considerable amount of expertise, Lloyd knew just what to say at a time like this. "Thank you, Your Majesty. Thank you for the contract. I shall relay the message to the queen how you happily accepted." This was the perfect time for a flat denial. Making up excuses would only backfire.

“Yes, please do. And do seriously think about the marriage proposal when you have the time.”

“I do not think it will happen for a long time.” With that, Lloyd dashed out of the palace and jumped on Draggy's back, fearing the monarch would stop him and ask the question again.

“Let’s go!”

Clang! Draggy soared into the air, smashing the remaining vases in the plaza as he took off, and messages appeared in front of his eyes announcing the birth of a new title.

Ding dong.

[You have successfully completed a large international project by gathering various groups of races together, threatening and fooling a number of elementals, and appeasing the king of a foreign land.]

[To this, the different races of creatures who joined the construction, the elementals who were duped, the outsiders who were used, and the demons who observed the entire scenario would all concur with your new title.]

[A new title, “Hell’s Top Talent,” has been created.]

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Chapter 359: Preparations to Meet the Queen (1)

[A new title, “Hell’s Top Talent,” has been created.]

Lloyd grinned as he was about to leave the Benetto Kingdom when a message appeared in front of his eyes.

Haha.

As expected, titles tended to appear at a later time, until the impacts of a project could clearly be seen in society. They rarely appeared right after construction was completed.

I suppose this is natural because civil engineering values pragmatism. A construction should result in something that is not just pretty and grand but useful to society at the end of the day.

Lloyd believed that the Pantara Railway would have a significant impact on international trade, similar to how the Suez and Panama Canal transformed the world of cargo transportation. He carefully scanned the messages.

[Hell’s Top Talent]

[Title Level: Hero’s Legacy]

Okay, it’s time to study the railway of the past. Open your History of Modern Civil Engineering Book to page 359. Yes. That’s the famous Pantara Railway, which I’m sure every one of you knows. Student in the front row. Could you briefly walk us through how this railroad came to be? Excellent. That’s correct. The Pantara Railway, just like what the student said, is a masterpiece built by Lloyd Frontera, who received an order from the Magentano House. Hahaha. Are you all bored? It’s Lloyd Frontera again. Look at this section, and you’ll find Lloyd Frontera. Move on to the next part, and you still find him. I, too, am sick of him. Had it not been for him, we would only have one-eighth of what we will study this summer. But what else can we do? That son of a gun set the groundwork for the civil engineering of our empire. So, it would be unfair if we were the only ones

to suffer, no? Let’s hit the books. Come now. Let’s study harder, create new theories, and make it harder for the students who’ll come after you all. All right, so the Pantara Railroad introduced the switchback system for the first time in the world...

[Compliment Effect: You used every means possible to finish the railroad in the Pantara Range. In this process, you tricked countless people who shuddered in shock and repulsion. The demons watching over you could not give you enough paise. As a result, countless residents of Hell and the undead have come to respect and admire you even more strongly.]

[Precaution: The affections of the demons may come at the expense of Hell’s King’s overwhelming desire to recruit you.]

[Title Region: All The Regions of the Human World and Hell]

[Active Period of Title: 1200 Years (Human world) / 750,000 Years (Hell)]

[A title’s powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region for which the compliment was given. Moreover, the time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 8]

[Current CP: 1,648]

Lloyd’s brows wiggled after finishing reading. It was all good and impressive.

But it feels like there’s a trap here.

Lloyd’s eyes focused on the word “Caution”.

Hell’s King’s overwhelming desire to recruit me?

Did that mean the Hell’s King would hire him after he died? Does it mean he would have to work his butt off even after death instead of resting? Something did not sit right with him.

I don’t like the idea of that.

Lloyd despised he thought of working in Hell with every fiber of his being. He was already tirelessly working every day and peace was something he couldn’t even dream about. He refused to still work after death.

Tsk. I need to look into this later.

It could backfire on him if he pushed this aside as nothing. However, there was other work he needed to take care of right now.

I need to finish the railroad construction here, return to the palace for the Tears of Summer, treat the side effect of absorbing the Heart of Winter, and then finally resolve the restoration of destiny.

He felt like a college student with a pile of assignments that couldn’t be pushed aside.

Tsk.

Feeling a surge of bitterness, Lloyd went back to the construction site for the railroad.

***

The railroad construction was finished without much problem. It was all thanks to the operation and maintenance procedures that Lloud thought of in advance.

“The train will run twice a day, morning and afternoon. But if there’s an overwhelming amount of cargo, that can be extended to a maximum of four. Don’t forget,” reminded Lloyd.

“There are dozens of cars attached to the long train. I wonder how it could get overwhelmed,” pointed out Javier.

Lloyd assured him that it would. “This railroad will carry goods from nearly everywhere across the southwest, beginning with the Benetto Kingdom and neighboring nations. Magentano Kingdom will also be sending many

freights to the southwest. Why? That would save months of travel time by avoiding a round trip. Think about all the risk factors, like encounters with mountain robbers and monsters, that would be eliminated. Even if they have to wait a month to be allocated, everyone will still hurry to utilize the facility. A month of waiting and paying a storage fee would be more cost-effective than months of circling the range."

To begin with, Lloyd planned for the train to make up to six roundtrips every day. That way there wouldn't be too many shipment delays.

"And that's why it wasn't for nothing when I built large-scale warehouses on both ends of the train platform. One here in the Magentano and the other in the Benetto Kingdom."

"You foresaw that the orders and items would be piled up."

"Yeah, and that is why I built the makeshift station at the rift's summit," Lloyd explained. The said station was built when the upward tracks were completed and the downward tracks were ready for construction. "Because you never know when emergencies might occur, and people who maintain the railway should have a place to live."

"You are right."

Sure, the construction was important, but so was its maintenance. With that in mind, Lloyd stated, "About 30 orcs and ten elves will be stationed there. They will check the railroad every day and be trained to make immediate repairs when necessary. I will also place elementals with them."

Lloyd chuckled as he spoke. He had not expected to get support from the elementals on the first leg of this project. But now, thanks to them, the number of laborers that would need to reside here could be significantly reduced since their lack of physical presence allowed them to travel around the track freely.

"That sounds like labor exploitation..." remarked Javier, finding Lloyd unbelievable.

Lloyd shrugged. “Not necessarily. There are countless low-level elementals.”

“Countless?”

“I asked the high-level elementals for a number, and they said it is about 60,000. I was told they’re going to be fine as long as they properly distribute the work amongst themselves.”

“Without pay…?”

“Free, my foot.” Lloyd chuckled. “You know I don’t believe anything’s free in the world. I hate putting people to work without compensating them as much as I hate doing things for free. Their labor will be compensated.”

“What kind of compensation?”

“I’ll make sure that no human will enter the entire range except the railroad zones. I’ll ask the queen to formalize it into a law. And besides, this place rarely has any human traffic in the first place.”

That was the deal Lloyd made with the high-level elementals. But Javier slightly frowned upon hearing it.

“It appears that your negotiation skill is becoming more evil day by day.”

“Eh? Why?”

“These mountains had no human traffic to begin with. Yet, you destroyed a part of the elementals’ home only to declare that you would protect it. I am not sure if you are shameless or sly.”

“Well,” said Lloyd. “I won’t deny it. Let’s say that I’m both.”

“I would not find you so spiteful if you didn’t admit it at the very least.”

“Consider it karma.”

Lloyd ultimately grinned. It was not in his plans to become an Elemental King. But now that he was, he wanted to make the most of it and believed that protecting the remaining untouched nature was the best he could do for them.

“Everyone’s happy. The elementals are happy with the deal, and I’m happy to have a larger workforce for the railroad’s maintenance.”

Just like that, he stayed a few more days at the site, looking over the operation of the railway and maintenance system one more time, supervising the quality of travel of four trains made up of ten cars, and providing basic education to the residential repairers.

“Are we clear? A few days later, there will be more help arriving from the Imperial House of Magentano,” promised Lloyd.

“You can leave it to us, oink!” the orcs replied.

“Tell them to bring lots of meat,” said the elves with a smile.

Then, it became time to say farewell and return home. In the reversed order of their arrival, the following groups departed from the site aboard Draggy: the engineers, White Cavalry lancers, elf archers, orcs (minus 350 train propellers and sand men), and Skeleton Corps.

Once everyone was back home safe, Lloyd turned to the capital. “Time to meet the queen!” And as soon as he arrived at Magenta, he made his way to the palace and requested an audience.

“I see, sir. I will inform Her Majesty. Please wait here.”

Lloyd waited just like the Lord Great Chamberlain said. And soon, the latter returned and said, “Her Majesty has agreed to meet you. Please, this way.”

Lloyd followed him down the corridor, and his heart felt an unexpected burst of sense of reward.

Ha... Finally. Just a few steps, and I’m done.

Lloyd’s huge picture, which he had created the instant he confronted the Minister of Angels in the sky, was now about to be realized. With only a few steps remaining, he felt delighted.

And, as promised, I will get my hands on the Tears of Summer. In the meantime, there won’t be a need to return to the capital for a while since I have no favors to ask from the queen. So, I will try to stay as far away from here as possible.

Lloyd didn’t want to get too close to the queen. Sure, she was being generous with her assistance and making things convenient for Lloyd. But he didn’t want to grow too close to her.

Never. Never.

He didn’t want it. Getting closer to the queen was the same as becoming a neighbor with a boss at work.

Sure, a huge wage is nice, but if it means giving up boundaries, that is uncomfortable. Why would I do that? My honeypot is already full, and I have got a strategy to keep it that way. I only need to stop destiny.

Lloyd made a mental note to distance himself from the queen after attaining the Tears of Summer. Just then, he noticed that he was being led to a different path.

What’s going on?

He looked around and was passing through the convoluted staircases and corridors. He was familiar with them but in a bad way.

This leads to the training center...

This wasn’t the way to her office. It was the way to the training hall that sat in the annex. Realizing that something was off at that moment, Lloyd asked, “Excuse me?”

“Yes, Young Lord. Is there something you wish to know?”

“I do. Why are we heading to the training hall?”

“Oh, I was about to tell you what Her Majesty has asked you to prepare.”

“Prepare?” Lloyd asked again, gulping involuntarily.

The Lord Great Chamberlain put on a meaningful smile. “Her Majesty issued a special order to have you come with a solid shovel, sturdy training clothes, and strong resolution.”

What the heck? Am I going to have a sparring session with her? But I just asked her for an audience. Why? Why is she trying to make me her punching bag?

Lloyd felt sick to his stomach after making sense of the situation. When he entered the training hall, he discovered something very unexpected.

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Chapter 360: Preparations to Meet the Queen (2)

“Ack! Argh!! Hargh...”

Clank! Lloyd wiped his sweaty face with his palm instead of picking up his metal shovel, which fell to the floor.

“Whoa...”

Lloyd felt his legs weaken and let his body fall to the ground. Even then, he was still short of breath. The fact made him feel a sense of resentment as deep and intense as a cup of espresso.

How is she standing there like nothing happened when I’m about to pass out from exhaustion?

Lloyd lifted his resentful gaze and saw the queen proudly standing tall in front of him. She was completely fine. There was no sign of struggle in her breaths and not a single strand of her hair was out of place.

“Are you tired already, Lloyd Frontera?”

“Argh... ‘Already’ is really an unfair word for you to say right now, Your Majesty,” gasped Lloyd.

“Harsh? Why so?”

“It has been... about an hour since I began training with you, Your Majesty. Yet, you say I’m already tired...”

“How is an hour of sparring a big deal?” Queen Magentano cocked her head to the side as if she couldn’t comprehend why Lloyd was uttering the time. “Isn’t this the proper way for a sparring session?”

“...”

“It is typical during a war to clash weapons, run around, then grapple on the ground for at least an hour. So this is obviously how training should be done

in order to prepare for one. Do you disagree?”

Lloyd wanted to protest that no one would be able to clash weapons, run, and grapple for an hour in a duel with a swordmaster who was using clubs as her weapon.

Goodness. I only came to report the completion of the Pantara Railroad to her.

Lloyd’s mind flew back to one hour ago as he berated his current situation, wherein he turned into her punching bag. When he arrived at the training hall, he was surprisingly met with Queen Magentano holding two clubs.

It was a scary sight. The smile on her face toward him was especially scary. She was smiling like a girl opening up a gift from her first love. Otherwise, she was gazing at him like he was a punching bag that was shipped via express delivery. The clubs in both of her hands made this seem even more true. And from then?

After that, she didn’t say anything much.

All she did was raise her clubs in an elegant manner and tell Lloyd to loosen his body. There was plenty of time for them to talk. He didn’t want to even think about what came afterward.

Fast forward to now, where I’m being beaten to a pulp.

The two clubs, which turned out to be two metal swords with smoothened edges, were a nightmare for Lloyd. Queen Magentano freely used them as though she was testing a new skill and piece of technology on Lloyd. Sure, the movement of her left sword was a little more awkward than the right, but overall, it was hard to avoid them.

Lloyd, on the other hand, didn't put up much of a fight. He was like a cricket in the face of a storm, and the difference in strength between them could be explained by the number of years they spent as swordmasters. Then, there was the matter of how they attained that level. Lloyd was aided by the Asrahan Core Technique and Supercharge skill, as well as an

increase in manaheart volume. Queen Magentano attained her strength through incredible talent and hard work. That produced an unbridgeable divide in their comprehension of bodily motions, mana, and sword functioning, and anticipated responses to each step, and it was this that robbed Lloyd of all energy within an hour.

“Ha... But Your Majesty,” said Lloyd as he wiped his perspiring face again. “May I reveal the purpose of my visit?”

“I know that already.” She chuckled and looked at her meaningfully. “To report the completion of the Pantara Range.”

“Did you know about it?” asked Lloyd, still panting.

“That is obvious.” She chuckled again, massaging her left arm. “It would be impossible for me not to know after your terrible fuss against the Benetto Kingdom.”

“...”

“Well, the report tells me that you did your job without any issues, so I shall not reproach you. I heard of you pulled quite a few tricks. You even succeeded in appeasing that old king.”

“I am filled with gratitude that you understand me so well, Your Majesty.”

“It would be harder for me not to. You can’t possibly think I don’t have eyes and ears outside the capital.”

“Well-”

“They are also in your fiefdom.” Her gaze flashed wonder for a second. “Which told me that you have the skill to manipulate time.”

“...”

“There is nothing to worry about,” Queen Magentano promised, “Because if I was jealous or on guard against you, I would have already hurt you earlier in our training session.”

“W-words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Majesty.”

“Really?”

“...”

“I see. I understand. I understand how you hope I will trust you that you are not after some avaricious goal. I understand.”

As she kept speaking, messages appeared just then.

Ding dong.

[Queen Magentano is putting up her guard due to your overly excellent skills.]

[The title <Magentano Carry> is activated.]

[Queen Magentano still has absolute trust in you. As such, despite her guard, she will not be hostile or hold suspicions against you.]

Her eyes softened as the messages appeared. “As such, I have already taken action that prohibits your people from revealing your powers to the outside world and executes anyone who violates it. Furthermore...” She paused and smiled meaningfully. “If anyone attempts to come between me and you with your time-control power, they, too, shall be executed.”

“W-Words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Majesty.” Lloyd hung his head down. He did feel grateful toward her for real this time.

I actually was going to inform her of that.

He expected such a story to be exposed quickly because he had stopped time once when constructing the Jewel of Truth.

I knew that stories of my strange power would eventually reach her anyway.

But it happened earlier than he expected. Lloyd figured that she was more interested in him than he thought.

Whew. So glad that I have the title.

Lloyd exhaled a sigh of relief, knowing that he could have been charged with treason if he had not had the title. She would not have left him alone since, despite her compassion, she was at the pinnacle of power and did not want any subject to threaten that, which was why Lloyd exhaled a sigh of relief.

“But Your Majesty,” said Lloyd as he looked around, “Us talking here...”

“It is all right. If you are worried about the possibility of those who might listen to us due to their swordmaster syndrome, you can rest assured.”

“Then...”

“Yes, I sent everyone away as soon as you requested the audience. There are only weaker guards here now, so our conversation will not reach their ears.”

“I am truly relieved. And as for your promise-”

“The Tears of Summer?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“I knew it. You are always like this.”

“Your Majesty?” asked Lloyd.

“You only ever look for me when you need something.”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.” Lloyd looked away.

“Forgive you?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Really?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Look me in the eye and say that again.”

“Please do not kill me, Your Majesty.”

“Tsk. You and your shamelessness.”

“Forgive me once again, Your Majesty.”

“If you are so sorry, then I might break my promise.”

“Your Majesty?” asked Lloyd.

“An idea dawned on me.”

“What is it...?” mumbled Lloyd, who looked worried.

“Since you only come to me when you need something from me, I had a thought about delaying the bestowal of the item for as long as possible. That way you will visit me until I am sick of you.”

“...”

“That is a satisfying thought. What do you think?” asked Queen Magentano.

“Ah, um, that’s-”

“What? Do you think I am sly?”

“...”

“Or are you pondering how you will beg?” asked Queen Magentano sharply.

“Please consider the position I am in, Your Majesty!” Lloyd fell to the ground.

A smile, which was as pure as gold, appeared on her face. “Good. I will do what you so desperately wish.”

Swoosh.

“Now that you have gotten enough rest, it is time for round two.” She then raised her sword with a bright smile.

A look of utter despair came over Lloyd’s face.

***

Lloyd remained bedridden for a few more days due to the rigorous training session. This time, too, he experienced serious muscle pain, but his perseverance had not been in vain.

Fortunately, Queen Magentano kept her word. She turned public sentiment in the country in her favor by making a domestic and international declaration about the completion of the trade route across the Pantara Range and commending Lloyd's work. No noble in the realm dared to oppose her. Everyone just followed the queen since they had agreed to the deal at the previous hearing presided over by the House of Peers. Those in support of bestowing the divine item to Lloyd rejoiced while the opposing side accepted their defeat. Everything went swimmingly.

A few days later, a bestowal ceremony was held, which could not have been more extravagant. Every noble in the kingdom came, including prominent figures from the provinces. The ceremony was grander than most small palatial events, and its size made Lloyd nervous. However, he was not nervous because he would see prominent figures attending the event, be bestowed a divine item, or attract everyone's attention.

This is a huge event. Up to now, something has always happened in every event regardless of size.

That was the state of his luck. It might have been because of some bizarre rule in this world, but whenever there was a celebration for anything, calamity struck.

Once at Cremo. And again here in the palace during the construction of the suspension bridge and the garden. Draggy once went bonkers. With today's event being bigger than ever before, anything can happen at any moment. So, please, never, ever let your guard down.

Lloyd was on pins and needles throughout the ceremony, jumping even at the fall of a napkin, but nothing happened this time. No accident broke out even when the event ended, and the only remarkable event that came close to disaster was getting so nervous and shouting, "I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Alicia!" when he received the chest containing the Tears of Summer.

Ha... It's a relief that I was able to quickly correct myself. Otherwise... Whew.

If he had sullied the queen's name in that way, history would remember him as the man who desecrated her name and got executed.

But it's fine since I got what I needed.

As he left the palace after the ceremony, Lloyd and Javier went to a secluded location outside the capital and went into the quiet woods to wait for the night to set in. At midnight, when the full moon was in full swing, Lloyd was ready to take the final action that would complete his grand plan.

"Are you ready?" asked Lloyd, his voice charged with excitement.

"Yes."

"Here we go."

"I understand, Young Master."

When Lloyd opened the container containing the Tears of Summer, an inexplicable heat flooded over him.

Fwoosh! Just then, Lloyd's Supercharge skill activated, absorbing every bit of heat possible to offset the grueling side effect of the Heart of Winter. As

heat seeped into his manaheart, it alarmed Pantalasa, the Elemental King enjoying a rare break inside.

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Chapter 361: Vacation Extension (1)

For nearly every office worker in society, vacation time was a source of comfort and what made living worthwhile. It was a magical period of rejuvenation, and that was not only true for South Koreans. Even here, it was also a priceless and exquisite delight for Pantalasa, the elemental king, who was happily enjoying his time off in Lloyd's manaheart.

Lying on his stomach in a corner of the manaheart, he was sprawled on a sunbed made of frigid mana. With a glass of snow juice with ice by his side, he enjoyed the freezing temperature of the pool. Pantalasa thought, "Ahh, how nice. This is what I am talking about. I had no idea that life could be this enjoyable. Ehem. Yes, yes." He could not be any happier. It felt like he was experiencing the happiest period of time in his life.

I can't believe I didn't experience this kind of joy in life until now.

He looked back on his life from the conception of the Pantara Range to the present day. Throughout his tens of millions of years in existence, Pantalasa didn't have a single moment of peace. His life was filled with constant worrying about the potential harm and environmental changes that could befall the range. He never once shied away from his duty and responsibilities.

I've never been able to rest like this before.

At first, he felt awkward about taking a break from his vacation and lounging around in Lloyd Frontera's manaheart. He questioned whether this was the correct course of action. However, now...

My dear Lloyd! Please live a long life! Please!

There was only one way for him to extend this lovely vacation of his. Lloyd needed to live a long life. Only then would he be able to enjoy the beautiful ice crystal, the Heart of Winter, for longer.

“I lay my eyes on the Heart of Winter each time, and... It looks awesome each time.”

Pantalasa rolled over and shifted his eyes above him, staring at the ice crystal reflecting in the manaheart’s sky. With awe in his eyes, he beheld the Heart of Winter. The latter returned the former’s sentiments by showering him with an even colder gust of air.

“Yes, this is what I’m talking about...” He swiveled around on the sunbed, enjoying the frigid air from the Heart of Winter. He secretly wished for this leisurely time of happiness to last as long as possible while drifting off to sleep.

Bzzt! Suddenly, he was roused from his slumber by a small, faint noise that came from the manaheart’s sky. It was an unsettling sound that he had never heard before here.

“Hmm?” He slightly opened his eyes, wondering what the noise could be. It sounded like something had cracked. He was about to go back to slumber, thinking that he had misheard, when...

Crash! A hole appeared in the manaheart’s sky. Then, an enormous amount of heat started to come down from it!

“Ack!!” He leaped to his feet in terror as a wave of searing heat crashed down onto the icy water.

Fwoosh.... He was suddenly attacked by a devastating shockwave along with a wave of steam as cold and hot air collided together.

“Eek!”

He flung his body by reflex and got down to the ground, propping up the sunbed to protect himself.

Sizzle... As he saw the sunbed made with the mana of icy air melt like ice cream in the summer sun.

“...”

This was serious. This was a nightmare. This was a disaster!

“Argh! Eek! What’s going on?”

Sensing danger, Pantalasa gathered the frigid energy in his body and summoned a blizzard with all his might.

Fwoosh! The glass of snow juice that he was leisurely sipping on and his happy vacation plans were blown away by the blizzard. He let out a few icy tears at this sight all the while trying to shield himself from the scorching heat.

“Ack! Argh!!!”

He felt extremely wronged by this sudden calamity and felt even more so as he thought about it. What in the world was going on now? All he did was enjoy the first vacation of his life. How did he deserve to get into this kind of awful disaster? Pantalasa became more upset the more he thought about it.

“Ack...!” He cried out in anger as he jumped around to avoid stepping on the heat. “Lloyd Fronteraaaa!”

♣

Ding Dong!

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option ⑤: Your Supercharge time is up.]

As the dinging noise pierced into his ears, there were messages simultaneously appearing in front of his eyes.

Ziiing... With the Supercharge skill coming to an end and his mana circle’s fierce rotations subsiding, Lloyd slowly opened his eyes. He looked down at the inside of the chest he was clutching.

It’s done.

The chest was empty. Upon realizing that the sunny marble had vanished, further messages began to appear before his eyes.

[You have absorbed the Tears of Summer, a divine item that possesses its own consciousness.]

[The Tears of Summer has an immense amount of influence over your manaheart.]

[The frigid air that accumulated in your manaheart as a side effect of absorbing the Heart of Winter is disappearing.]

This was the message Lloyd had been waiting for so long. His confrontation with the angel, mind games with the queen and the House of Peers, and railroad construction in the rough mountain range had all been for him to hear these words. And now, it was finally done. He could feel the success of his work throughout his entire body.

Haah...

In the recesses of his heart, a strange sensation started to bloom from one side of his chest. It initially felt like a small candle was lit inside him, but the warm sensation quickly intensified, becoming more like a torch to a bonfire until it burned like a furnace. The feeling spread like wildfire and engulfed his manaheart.

This reminds me of those rotating devices in salons that emit heat on your hair after it's treated for a perm.

In the same way that the sun and a hot pack thaw your icy fingers, Lloyd could feel the Tears of Summer that he had just consumed with Javier beginning to impact his manaheart. Heat blanketed his chest, heart, and manaheart like someone had held his hand or gave him a hand warmer in the middle of winter at an active construction site.

The cold air is disappearing.

The cold air, which had been accumulating inside him like cancer every time he used the Heart of Winter, began to dissipate. He felt refreshed as if he was chugging a bowl of hot soup on a winter's night. Eventually, he was met with a series of even more welcoming messages.

Ding dong.

[The frigid air of the Heart of Winter that had been lingering in your manaheart is now gone.]

[The power of season laden in the Tears of Summer seeped into your manaheart. This experience is having a strong effect on your manaheart skill.]

[A new manaheart skill option has been opened.]

[Manaheart Skill Option ⑦: Momentary Precognition]

What?

Lloyd squinted his eyes.

Momentary Precognition?

Lloyd was not surprised about gaining a new skill. He had anticipated it when he absorbed the Heart of Winter the last time.

I earned the Time Freeze skill with the Heart of Winter. And now... Momentary Precognition? Is it some sort of foresight ability?

He began to carefully read the skill description.

[Skill Option ⑦: Momentary Precognition - The power of the Tears of Summer in your manaheart can accelerate the time axis recognized by your soul. If this happens, you can take a sneak peek of what will happen.]

[Additional Information (1): The limit of your prediction is contingent on the size and volume of your manaheart and mana. Currently, you

can see up to five seconds into the future.]

[Additional Information (2): Each time you activate the skill, the Tears of Summer will emit a massive amount of heat. The heat will accumulate in your body immediately, and your body temperature will increase by 1℃.]

[Additional Information (3): Overuse of the skill may dramatically increase your body temperature and negatively affect your health and life.]

[Additional Information (4): If you set the skill to activate automatically in times of danger, you will automatically see the future in situations that jeopardize your safety and life.] I

[Would you like to configure it to run automatically?]

[YES / NO]

Okay...

After finishing the message, Lloyd clenched his hand. The skill he earned was better than he had expected it to be.

I can see five seconds into the future? This is amazing.

Some might think it was nothing, but to Lloyd, it was something. He thought he hit the jackpot, in fact.

This can be used in countless different ways. It could help me avoid dying in a dangerous situation.

The fact was that Lloyd had accomplished practically everything. His family was secure, and his future was brighter than the sun. The only assignment remaining was destiny, and once that was completed, his entire life would be paradise.

But still, you never know what kind of misfortune might happen to you.

Even if he was the swordmaster, history was littered with swordmasters who died at the hands of bad luck and misfortune. Lloyd was no exception. So, this type of safe skill was a good one to have.

The more, the better.

Lloyd chose “YES” because he believed that safety was the most important factor.

[Skill Option ⑦: You have set the skill to automatically activate in times of danger.]

Great.

Lloyd then turned to the side, satisfied to have solved the Heart of Winter situation and acquired a handy skill.

“Is it done, sir?” Javier asked as if he had been waiting for Lloyd to be done. His eyes were glowing.

“Yeah,” Lloyd replied with glee.

“Did it go well?”

“What do you think?”

“I can tell from that distinct smile of yours that you are satisfied enough.”

“My smile?”

“Yes?” replied Javier in a cold and sharp way. “There is a certain smile you put on when your plans go smoothly. However, it looks like you are oblivious to it.”

“Yeah? How do I smile?” asked Lloyd with anticipation.

“It makes me want to distance myself from you the moment I see it.”

“...”

“But it is all right,” comforted Javier. “No need to get depressed.”

“Why do you say that?”

“Well, you do not have many people you are close to in the first place.”

“Hey.”

“Yes?”

“That’s harsh. You may not know it, but I’ve got a lot of people in my social circle.”

“Oh, you do?” Javier asked.

“Of course.”

“Then tell me, Young Master.”

“Huh?”

“I mean, name the people in your social circle.”

“...”

“They cannot be your parents and brother, can they?”

“...”

“Or was I the first person you thought of?”

“...”

“I feel sorry for you. Tsk, tsk.”

“Hey,” called Lloyd seriously.

“Yes?”

“Thank you.”

“Come again?”

“How about you just accept my gratitude, and we can call it even...”

“Hmph.”

Lloyd trembled briefly as it appeared Javier had become a master at pulverizing one’s ego. Despite the latter’s talent for throwing truth bombs, he felt appreciative.

I wouldn’t have dared to absorb the Tears of Summer without him.

The same thing happened when he absorbed the Heart of Winter. At first, he thought he accomplished it all by himself, but after some reflection, he realized that was not the case.

It was only after I absorbed it that I learned about its terrifying force.

That is when he understood there was no way he could have absorbed it on his own. He concluded that Javier’s help must have been used to make it happen.

And I was right.

That was why Lloyd immediately sought Javier for assistance in absorbing the Tears of Summer, and the latter was happy to oblige.

He really is incredible.

Lloyd felt reassured by Javier’s presence as he gazed at him. He could not have gotten this far without the knight. Therefore, he did not want to lose Javier and hoped they would keep bickering with each other for eternity.

“Hey! Lloyd Frontera!”

Lloyd was quietly making a wish to himself when an enraged voice from Pantalasa emerged from the corner of his manaheart.

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Chapter 362: Vacation Extension (2)

“Hey, Lloyd Frontera!”

Lloyd knitted his brows in response to the loud, angry shout. He immediately recognized where it was coming from.

“*You surprised me. What’s going on? I thought you were taking a vacation.”* Lloyd asked Pantalasa inside his manaheart.

“*Vacation, my ass! I almost died!”* snapped Pantalasa right away.

“Eh? Why?”

“Are you seriously asking because you don’t know?”

Lloyd wondered why Pantalasa was so offended. He soon found out why.

“*What was that heat pouring into your manaheart? It almost melted me away into nothing!”*

“Eh?”

“Eh, my foot! Explain yourself!” bawled Pantalasa.

“Um, I’m not trying to make excuses. I honestly didn’t know about this. Sorry,” Lloyd admitted right away, having forgotten about the elemental in his manaheart. “I already made plans to absorb the Tears of Summer a while ago and have merely been working towards my final goal until now. Today just happened to be the day for it. But I never gave you a warning beforehand. That was my fault. I’m so sorry.”

Lloyd knew it was pathetic to become defensive and give out a string of excuses when he did something wrong. Keeping this in mind, he fully admitted his mistake.

“And what about you? Are you all right?”

“All right?” Pantalasa’s voice was still gruff, but Lloyd could see it had softened. *“I nearly died. That was the most brutal heat I’ve ever experienced.”*

“Still, it looks like you lived.”

“Are you mocking me?”

“I’m saying that I’m glad that you’re alive.”

“You are mocking me.”

“Well, there’s not much I can say to convince you otherwise.”

Lloyd shrugged, getting a vague sense of what his elemental friend experienced.

“It was exactly as if someone poured a bucket of hot water on you while you were happily cooling off in front of the AC, right?”

“I don’t know what an AC is, but you’re right about a bucketful of water. So, I want to make a complaint. This wasn’t a part of our promise.”

“Eh? Hold it right there. We never made a promise like that,” clarified Lloyd.

“What?” Pantalasa stopped.

“I’m telling you the truth. You asked me if you could stay in my manaheart, and I agreed. In that process, did I ever promise you that my manaheart or the environment inside it would stay the same? I don’t remember doing so.”

Pantalasa didn’t say anything.

“I’m sorry that I didn’t inform you about this earlier, but it’s not a violation of any promise. It’s morally wrong, but legally? Not so much.”

“Ha! You are unbelievable...” Pantalasa’s voice started to sound angry again.

Lloyd, on the other hand, did not care one bit. He said he was sorry and saw no reason to go any further and compensate him for what happened.

“Then, what do you want? You can lash out at me and protest all you want. However, the inside of my manaheart isn’t going to become cold again like before since I’ve already absorbed the Tears of Summer. So, choose for yourself.”

“Choose what?”

“Stay in my manaheart or go back to the Pantara Range.”

“...”

“I’ll give up my position as the elemental king and return it to you if that’s what you want,” said Lloyd frankly. This was the best he could do. *“From my perspective, you’ll simply be going back to where you belong, and everything will go back to its original state. Of course, I’ll lose the elementals I planned to use for the maintenance of the railroad. However, that’s something I’ll accept as the price I’m paying for the harm I caused you. How does that sound?”*

“...”

Lloyd’s straightforward and honest offer came as a surprise to Pantalasa, who remained silent for a second after hearing those words. Then, he composed himself and reflected on what he wanted. After a moment of contemplation, the answer easily came to him.

“I don’t want to,” said Pantalasa.

“What? You don’t want to?”

“That’s right. I don’t want to go back.”

“To the Pantara Range? Why’s that?” Lloyd cocked his head because he could not wrap his brain around it. He believed Pantalasa would be glad to accept the offer, but he was mistaken.

Pantalasa was firm.*“If you are asking me why... It’d be a waste to end my vacation here.”*

“Haha?”

“I haven’t even had the chance to properly enjoy my break after billions of years of work. Yet, I have to go back right this moment to the Pantara Range and resume my role as the elemental king? That feels a bit unfair.”

Lloyd grasped Pantalasa’s point immediately. *“I understand what you are saying. Well, to a certain extent. It would be similar to if an employee was summoned back to their company due to an emergency on their first day of vacation. Anyone would get upset in that situation. Even if it was a monk or priest, they would probably lose their temper and start yelling.*”

“I don’t know what you mean by a monk or priest, but yes. Somewhat. I don’t want to end my rare vacation here and go back.”

“Do you plan to continue staying in my manaheart then?” asked Lloyd.

“No.”

“What?”

“It’s gotten too hot there to stay. But I don’t want to end my vacation right now and go back to the Pantara Range. I don’t like either option.”

“What do you want then?” asked Lloyd with annoyance.

“Show me a place that is as cold as how it used to be inside your manaheart,” Pantalasa replied in an instant.

“Hm? If I do, are you planning to enjoy the rest of your vacation there?”

“Exactly. By chance, is there any place you have in mind?”

“Hmm...” Lloyd pondered as Pantalasa’s suggestion didn’t sound so bad. *“Let’s see...”*

Lloyd racked his brain and thought about a place Pantalasa would enjoy staying in. Of course, he quickly found the answer. It would be the coldest place in the world and somewhere that he had visited before. A place that would benefit from just the mere presence of Pantalasa.

“If you love the cold so much... How about going to the North Pole?”

“North Pole?” Lloyd’s question made Pantalasa’s heart pound.

♣

His suggestion of the North Pole had beautiful outcomes. It pleased not only Lloyd and Pantalasa but the mermaids in the area as well. It was a win-win situation for everyone.

“I’ve never known that such a beautiful place existed!”

Pantalasa had not stepped a foot anywhere outside the Pantara Range for the past tens of millions of years until now. The only exception to this was inside Lloyd’s manaheart. And so, he was shocked and goggle-eyed as soon as he arrived at the North Pole. The sea was covered in sheets of ice. There were glaciers floated around wherever he laid his eyes. Moreover, the biting winds were so cold they nearly pierced through his skin. Everything was perfect except for one thing.

What’s that? Something strange is hanging in the sky.

Panatalasa. who had been endlessly praising the North Pole ever since he came out of Lloyd’s manaheart, pointed to the sky. There was a large, blazing chasm where he gestured. It was the Hell Gate, which served as a bridge to the other realm. Pantalasa’s gaze sharpened at the sight of the Hell Gate.

“This place is fantastic. I like everything about it except for that. What’s that ugly thing doing in this beautiful place? Why is there a grotesque hole emitting fiery heat into this wonderfully cold air?”

It appeared that Pantalasa was not fond of the Hell Gate. He moved before Lloyd could even get in a word, using all of his strength to create an icy storm and force it into the gate against the intense heat. As if he were an AC countering a heater, the former king challenged his opponent to a fight. Unexpectedly, Pantalasa won, and his strategy involved fixing an icy storm directly in front of the gate to neutralize the heat coming out of it. This method turned out to be sufficient to lower the temperature from the heat.

The heat from the Hell Gate had been raising the temperature of the planet for a while now. However, the problem had been resolved at long last. The merpeople cheered out in delight. Lloyd felt a sense of relief watching them.

“You look like you have removed a bothersome weight off your shoulders,” observed Javier coolly.

“Well, you’re not completely wrong,” admitted Lloyd.

Whoosh... Lloyd shrugged his shoulders on top of Draggy’s hand as he left the North Pole waters. He flashed a wide grin at Javier, who was narrowing his eyes at him, and asked, “Still, everyone’s happy in the end, right?”

It was a win-win scenario. Lloyd had killed three birds with one stone: Pantalasa was allowed to continue his vacation, the merpeople fixed the global warming conundrum, and Lloyd solved the problem that troubled him. He practically performed a miracle.

“Now, it’s time to go to the capital and say hi,” announced Lloyd.

“To whom?” asked Javier.

“To the queen.” It was time, Lloyd thought. He already obtained the Summers of Tears. To be honest, he had no business with the queen.

From now on, I’ve to find out how I can stop the restoration of destiny.

That was what occupied his thoughts as he traveled to the capital, requested an audience with the queen, and walked to the queen’s office. Of course, he

would not be able to find a solution in such a short moment. However, he still put a lot of effort into finding another answer to the dilemma of choosing between his life and Javier's.

But it doesn't matter.

Time was on his side, at least according to the previous Ending Spoiler, and he had about two years before destiny kicked into high gear. Until then, he only needed to think harder, study harder, and work harder. He could find the solution within two years. Lloyd believed that there was an answer somewhere that didn't require sacrificing himself or Javier. With it, he direly hoped he could live a normal and leisurely life.

I want that to be the case.

His life had been filled with nothing but struggle. That was why he wanted to live a normal life. He wanted a leisurely life with no tragedies or worries about tomorrow. Lloyd wanted to experience a new era of his life that he could look back at without any regrets.

I'll make it happen.

Lloyd cautiously hoped to himself, but he also strengthened his will to work hard for two more years to make his goal a reality at any cost. He reassured himself that he could achieve it and was capable of doing so. Then, he entered the queen's office to bid her farewell as well as explain he was returning to his fiefdom and would not return to the capital for a bit.

"I, Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera County, am honored to be in the audience of the rightful owner of this land," Lloyd announced once he was in. His plan was to tell her that he needed to return to his fiefdom because his business in the capital was finished. Then, the young lord prepared his next words, making sure they sounded polite and gentle so as not to offend the queen.

But as the queen turned to face him, when he saw the slight grin on her face. His thoughts turned blank.

Hold on.

As Queen Alicia turned around to him, her left arm made an awkward movement in that short period of time. It almost seemed paralyzed or unresponsive from the anesthetic. She attempted to hide the fact from Lloyd. However, he saw the brief motion of her arm, and something sprang into his brain.

Left arm paralysis.

The Ending Spoiler. The paralysis of Queen Alicia's left arm. When the thought entered Lloyd's mind, he realized instinctively that he was mistaken about having more than enough time and that the moment had already arrived for him to make a decision.

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Chapter 363: Fourth Ending Spoiler (1)

Left arm paralysis.

Lloyd's thoughts rushed back to the images he saw from the Ending Spoiler. He had seen how this narrative would end if nothing changed from here and gathered countless clues from the foresight. Queen Magentano was one of the people in it.

Her left arm is supposed to get cut off in the novel, but my intervention allowed her to remain unharmed. But the restoration of destiny interfered and made my efforts useless. Eventually, her arm became paralyzed and lost its function.

A chill ran up his spine. The unusual movement of her arm remained stuck in his mind. Lloyd couldn't forget what he saw. He felt a suffocating sense of unease.

But why? Why now?

It was incomprehensible. He should have a good two more years before the restoration of destiny began, according to the Ending Spoiler.

Is it happening earlier?

He thought that could be the case but also felt resistant to the possibility.

Let's get a confirmation first.

Lloyd steadied his heart. He could not make a big deal out of it yet, so he had to identify the issue as calmly and objectively as possible. With that, he fixed the expression on his face after losing control over it for a moment and calmly bowed to the queen.

"Ha. You are always like this," Queen Magentano remarked.

"Your Majesty?"

“It is extremely mysterious how every single one of your visits has such perfect timing.”

“F-forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“Forgive you?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd.

“For what?”

“...”

“Tsk, I was simply muttering. I thought I could take a short break before lunch after finishing my morning business earlier than usual, but you intruded.”

“...”

“However, I understand you. You must have a matter of grave, vital, and pressing reason to interrupt my precious and pleasurable break, yes?”

“...”

“Why are you not answering?”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty, um,” Lloyd said hesitantly and awkwardly, begging secretly that she would not summon him to a duel. He added, “I asked an audience with Your Majesty because...”

“What is it?”

“I was worried about you.”

A look of surprise came over her. “Me? You? Worried?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd gravely.

“Really?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“I do not think so,” denied Queen Magentano.

“I am being genuine, Your Majesty.”

“Hmm... Did you do something wrong behind my back?”

“Certainly not, Your Majesty.”

“Murder, robbery, arson, fraud, embezzlement, etc...”

“Certainly not, Your Majesty,” pressed Lloyd again.

“Do you need more money from me?”

“That is not the case, Your Majesty.”

“Your denial only convinces me that I am right.” By now, she was almost convinced that was the case.

“Please trust me, Your Majesty.”

“How could I trust you?” A faint smile hung on the queen’s face. “You have never come to visit unless you had a matter of business to discuss with me. Was there ever an exception to this? Hmm, not even once.”

“However, do you not recall how I carried you on my back and-”

“Ran?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“And how much that cost me.”

“Surely, your well-being, happiness, and longevity of life cannot be given a monetary value,” assured Lloyd.

“Are you suggesting that I must trust you since you protected my well-being, happiness, and longevity of life?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd dropped his head down again and hastily sneaked a peek at her. She seemed joyful, but it was difficult to assess her left arm since it was not moving. Eventually, Lloyd decided to pull no punches. “The thing is, Your Majesty, if I may be honest, I am concerned about your left arm.”

Her face froze for a second.

“I noticed this during our recent training session,” Lloyd remarked. “Forgive me for bringing it up, but I noticed the awkward movements of your left arm. Although it was not very noticeable, there was something off.”

“...”

“As such, I have been considering for the past few days if your left arm was okay and what I could do to help.”

“Hmm... How interesting.” Queen Magentano chuckled and gave a response that seemed to say that there was no need for any fuss. “I sprained.”

“Excuse me?”

“I overtrained myself to the point where I sprained my shoulder and elbow after realizing I could soar to a higher caliber. It must have been greed.” Her voice was cool and calm.

“But the way your left arm moved-”

“Lloyd Frontera.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Do I look different today?”

“Your Majesty?”

“I am asking if you notice anything different in me today.”

Lloyd winced with curiosity. He had intended to inquire more about the unusual motion of her left arm since it was clearly not caused by a sprain. He wanted to dig deeper and find out more about it, but she wasn’t allowing it by throwing an off-topic question.

What’s she doing?

He wasn’t sure how to answer her. It was as if she suddenly became his girlfriend, who wanted to find out if he’d notice anything different in her.

I should just throw any answer and ask her about her left arm again.

In order to take the lead in the discussion, he realized he had to answer her. He clenched his eyes tightly, much as he did when he was a kid trying to distinguish between two identical drawings. “Um...” He then found it quickly.

“Did you not find it yet?” she hurried.

“No, Your Majesty! I found it.”

“What is it?”

“Um, forgive me for saying this to you... But you look ten years younger than usual.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd said seriously, and he could figure out why she was so young.

She’s not wearing any makeup. None.

It was Lloyd’s first time ever to look at her without any makeup.

“I should appear to be younger than usual. Of course, yes. After all, I go through various procedures to make myself look older.” She then sat on the couch, crossed her knees, and rubbed her left arm. Lloyd didn’t understand what she meant when she chuckled. “It may be unknown to you, but I was a daughter of a collateral line far from the main bloodline of the royal family.”

Lloyd was aware of that, but he was in the dark as to why she was bringing it up. Unfortunately, he was not given the opportunity to respond to her inquiry.

“Clearly, I fell far behind the line of succession. There were too many competitors, and I was much younger than them. A misstep would have sent me plunging off the edge. That was the life I led during my late adolescence. However, there was one advantage I had over my rivals.” Her monologue continued. “Great swordsmanship? No. It was something else entirely. Growing up in a remote province, I was one of only a handful of people who knew my name, and I made the most of that weapon.”

“Then, wait-”

“I lied about my age. Although I had defeated all my rivals for the throne, even something as trivial as my youthfulness could be used against me. So, I pretended I was 30 at the coronation ceremony when I was only 21 years old.”

“Oh.”

“The same thing happened afterward. I had to demonstrate the kind of authority that befit my throne lest anyone should accuse me of being unfit for my position because my crown did not compel obedience from the others.”

Lloyd tightly sealed his lips. He could tell the meaning behind her smile.

Okay, that’s why she’s been caking her face with makeup to look older. Her actual age is... She’s older than me but not too much.

Nonetheless, she was still older than Lloyd.

“Only a chosen few are granted access to this secret. Among them are the Great Lord Chamberlain, Sir Kyle, who betrayed me, and now you.”

“Why are you telling this secret, Your Majesty?” asked Lloyd innocently.

When she crossed her other leg, she asked, “Do you not know what I am doing?” She then said, “Secrets can be both my weakness and my weapon.” She stood tall and looked at him with the gaze of a queen.

Lloyd took in her words, thinking.

“Does that answer your question?”

Lloyd gulped. “Yes, Your Majesty.”

“I see. I appreciate you for understanding me.”

With a deep bow, Lloyd said, “I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.” At this point, he understood what she meant.

In other words, she’s requesting me to keep quiet about the condition of her left arm.

That suggested there was something wrong with her left arm, and it was not just a sprain from overtraining.

She, too, recognizes that this is not a simple injury. She knows something is wrong with her left arm, even if she is not sure what it is, and that it’s becoming worse.

Lloyd reasoned that if anyone could feel the abnormality in her left arm, it was the queen herself. She was a swordmaster, so she must be sensitive to changes in her bodily condition. It would be strange if she didn’t feel the paralyzing feeling on her arm.

But she’s requesting me to ignore her arm since it would become her weakness the minute it’s made public. That’s why she’s not even seeking

basic treatment for it.

At this rate, Lloyd had to accept it.

Something's wrong with her arm. And that means...

Destiny was on the move, and while he had no understanding of why it was occurring two years faster, it was. And if that is the case...

I have to come up with a plan.

Lloyd's heart started to palpitate rapidly, and the world around him became so black and blurry that he could not recall how he bid farewell to the queen. Before he knew it, he was outside the palace, on his way home, with only one idea in his mind.

I must use and check with the Ending Spoiler.

The only way to be certain was to use the Ending Spoiler to see how the present situation was changed and concluded.

Please.

He turned to his lodging, direly hoping that no one connected to him would suffer an untimely death. He bided his time until nightfall, when the bugs began to cry and the moon began to shine. At last, Lloyd tucked Javier into bed with a lullaby and entered the sitting room. He then opened the skill window.

[Skill Name: Ending Spoiler]

[Skill Feature: Absolute Authority]

[Required CP: 160 (Fourth)]

[You can take a peek at the portion of the ending scene that will unfold in this story by spending some of the CP. It could be a happy or sad ending.]

The familiar skill windows cascaded in front of his eyes. He took a deep breath.

Let's do it.

Lloyd selected the activate button at the bottom of the skill window.

[Skill Name: Would you like to use the Ending Spoiler?]

[Required RP: 160 (Fourth)]

[Current CP: 1,648]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a yes.

Ding dong.

[Skill Name: Ending Spoiler has been activated.]

[You have used 160 CP.]

[Current CP: 1,488]

The skill activation message popped up in front of him.

Crackle...! The flow of time around him gradually slowed until it finally stopped. The air in the sitting room and the drifting clouds visible through the windows... Everything came to a standstill, and the space in front of Lloyd flickered. *Bzzt!*

A new, round passage opened.

Whew.

Lloyd was always rattled during these moments. That was especially the case this time. He felt much more apprehensive than excited.

I have to gather as many clues as possible.

He was determined to gather as much information as possible in order to understand the reason why the events in the ending spoiler were happening earlier and what would happen from now until the future he was shown. With a strong resolve, he advanced toward the gateway and entered it. Then, a brilliant flash of light blinded his eyes.

Fwoosh! His vision turned dark as if he had squinted his eyes. As his blurry vision became clear, he could slowly see pieces of his surroundings. Lloyd's eyes soon snapped open in shock.

What in the world is this?

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Chapter 364: Fourth Ending Spoiler (2)

Bzzt! Lloyd strode into a bluish portal in one of the sitting rooms of the Magentano Palace, and then he disappeared. The world, which had halted for a second, then resumed its course. The clouds in the sky and the air in the sitting room started to move. The same was true for Javier's breathing and closed eyes as he pretended to sleep. Everything quietly began shifting, rising, and sparkling.

"..."

Javier softly arose from his dim bedroom and looked toward the direction of the sitting room. He could sense Lloyd's presence from there, but when he walked inside...

He is not here.

Javier searched the area but could not find Lloyd. However, he could hear his young master's gentle breathing and even swallowing his spit. Suddenly, he remembered a similar incident from when they were working on the massive waterways. He went to Lloyd's bedroom to get a report, but even though he sensed Lloyd's presence, the actual man could not be found. Javier checked behind the curtains, under the bed, and under the desk. Yet, even with his careful inspection, Lloyd was nowhere to be found.

"..."

Javier wondered how many secrets this fake Lloyd held to himself and what the latter was up to.

"He had a troubled expression on his face earlier."

Lloyd was fine when he left for the palace to say goodbye. However, his expression was completely different by the time he returned. Although it was not obvious, Javier was able to tell there was a change. The knight could detect even the smallest shift in his depraved young master's facial expression after all the years they spent by each other's side.

He was rattled and shaking. Tense.

At the same time, his young master looked determined and seemed to be hiding his nerves when singing the lullaby. Javier wanted to know what was making Lloyd so nervous, afraid, and anxious… And if he could be of any assistance.

That was why I did something I normally wouldn't.

Javier pretended to sleep, which was easy with his talents as a grandmaster. He tricked Lloyd by shutting his eyes tight until he detected a movement from him.

It is strange. I opened my eyes as soon as I felt his flow of mana. He disappeared during that split second.

Where had Master Lloyd gone? Was he all right? How could his presence be felt but not seen? And why was he groaning in pain like someone who had been hurt?

It is like he is having a nightmare.

With a sigh, Javier contemplated in the dark room, wondering whether he should wait for Lloyd or return to his pretend sleep and how he was going to help. It seemed the latter was in a predicament that he could not discuss with others. The night deepened as he thought over these worries.

♣

As the sun started to set in the world of the Ending Spoiler, Lloyd tried to squint his eyes to avoid the bright sunlight but failed to do so. His eyelids wouldn't move as he wanted them to. The trivial incident made him remember something.

Oh, right. I can't move my body right now.

It was always like this with the Ending Spoiler. He would see his future through the dying body of his future self and had no physical control over himself.

Tsk.

Despite the intensely bright light, Lloyd made an effort to investigate his surroundings.

“Master Lloyd, I am here,” said a familiar voice. It belonged to Javier.

Lloyd then felt something silky over his shoulder. Clothes, perhaps? Lloyd could not move and felt drained. His stomach also churned with severe nausea as if he was having a dreadful hangover.

I am on my death bed, after all.

This was the fourth ending spoiler, so even though Lloyd was watching his last moments play out in front of him, he was able to maintain his composure. This was the moment for careful observation rather than sentimentality, and every conversation and piece of information needed to be gathered. With that in mind, he observed what was happening and then heard a rustling noise next to him, which he assumed was Javier taking a seat.

“Javier.” Lloyd felt his own mouth speak.

Javier replied at once. “Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“I have something to say.”

“Please tell me.”

“It might take up quite a bit of your time.”

“That is fine.” Javier’s voice, however, shook. Even though it was firm, there was a slight tremble at the end of his words.

“This Ending Spoiler is horrible, isn’t it?” Future Lloyd chuckled.

“Master Lloyd?”

“Just keep listening. I don’t have much time left to explain.”

“...”

“It began right after the construction for the Pantara Railroad was finished. You probably sensed that there was a problem with the queen’s left arm. Your suspicion was correct. Don’t forget this.”

Even though his speech was strained, Lloyd persisted in speaking as clearly as possible. His words seemed to be directed toward Javier and also like a monologue at the same time.

Wait a minute. Is he talking to me?

It appeared that way, and Lloyd tried to concentrate on what his future self was saying. “Her left arm will grow worse. It will happen more quickly than expected. I wish it was a simple case of paralysis. But it was worse in this version of the phenomenon. In just two months, her arm started to decay as if it was infected with some sort of disease.”

What? Her arm would decay? Lloyd tensed at his gruesome words.

His future self continued, “So, she decided to cut it off since it wasn’t getting better with any kind of treatment and leaving it alone could endanger her life. She clenched her teeth and cut it off by herself. Do you see where I’m going with this? You’re right. The Knight of Blood and Iron. The assassination attempt. The outcome of the events was far too similar to what happened there.”

What in the world...

Lloyd was taken aback since the future appeared to be worse than what he saw with the first version of the restoration of destiny.

And... it’s closer to the original version of the Knight of Blood and Iron.

Lloyd’s breathing slowed. He began listening to his future self’s story with more focus.

Future Lloyd paused for a moment. Then he said, “After that, it’s pretty similar. Her temper changes. The amputation must have been a great shock

for her. Well, I suppose that would be the same for anyone and especially the case for the queen since she's a swordmaster. The loss of an arm was probably more devastating for her than most people. Anyway... She soon became suspicious of the people around her. I think she believed that her arm became paralyzed because someone was contaminating her food with small doses of poison. This led her to execute every servant in the palace. And as if that was not enough, she also executed every royal magician with them as well. Do you know why?"

Lloyd had no clue. But he had his guesses.

"You guessed it," said Future Lloyd. "She had doubts. She suspected that her arm was cursed rather than poisoned. And that is how every royal magician was sentenced to death. The House of Peers protested because most of their children worked in such jobs. Yes, that was the start of the civil war."

Lloyd imagined the events as he listened to the story. The queen had cast suspicion on everyone and then launched a bloody purse, just like in The Knight of Blood and Iron.

Then, a civil war broke out.

It appeared as though the same event had transpired in the future as the civil war had devastated half the land, burned down innumerable villages and farmland, and destroyed more than half of nobles.

"It was a huge war between two factions in support or opposition of the queen. You might be wondering which side our family chose. Of course, we sided with her. I made the decision after careful consideration and knew which team the goddess of victory would side with."

Lloyd thought that was much like him. He would have done the same thing.

"Of course, I didn't take part because I didn't want a pointless war. Let us say I was on the neutral side. Thankfully, she did not ask much of me. She must have been discreet. But she did something else that made things worse between us."

He wondered what she did. The answer made his blood run cold.

“Around the time the civil war ended, she waged war with another nation to control the atmosphere in the kingdom and solidify the nobles, and she invaded the southwest. The Benetto Kingdom.”

He couldn’t believe it. Chills ran down his spine.

“The trade route became an invasion route, and the kingdom fell in less than ten days, which is when I voiced my opposition. The route was not meant for invasion, but the price of my opposition was more costly than I thought. The title of Magentano Carry, meaning the one holding up the Magentano family.”

The title was withdrawn?

Magentano Carry was the first title Lloyd ever earned, granting him unconditional support and trust from the queen. He didn’t need to hear more to know the events that followed after that title was withdrawn during her tyrannous reign.

“I’m assuming you must have sensed it by now. Yeah, the doubts began to focus on me, and the wall that protected her from seeing past my family’s strength and power crumbled.” Future Lloyd chuckled. “I was marked as a traitor, and the entire kingdom became my enemy. So what did I do? I fought back. There was no room for negotiation in the first place. And that resulted in a second civil war. Guess who came out on top?”

Lloyd knew who won. “You should know. Yes, we won. We subdued the palace 15 days ago,” revealed Future Lloyd.

“...”

“And I planned to stop this whole nonsense afterward. But she had other plans for herself. She ended her own life.”

“...”

“That was one development to the story, so I just watched how things would play out, how that ugly reality would continue its messy and dirty path, and that is when I learned that a person’s life can be destroyed at lightning speed. Yesterday, I buried Count and Countess Frontera.”

What could have happened? Lloyd wondered.

“While I was out fighting in the war, a noble in support of the queen sent someone over. They approached the count and countess while pretending to be on my side and had an urgent message to deliver. Then... the two were attacked before they even realized what was happening.”

“...”

“Of course they had guards. I’m not so thoughtless as to leave my fiefdom unguarded, but that noble was a nomadic sword master traveling from one kingdom to the next.”

“...”

“In any case, my entire body feels weak from all the bottles of drinks I had last night. My heart is tortured by how I was not able to tell them the truth and that I love them. My guilt is eating me alive. So, I went on a drinking binge for the first time in a while. That was when it came to me.” Future Lloyd chuckled, and it allowed Lloyd to see why he was seeing this scene through the Ending Spoiler. “That’s right. I’m sure you, Lloyd Frontera, know of the Ending Spoiler. My past self. You’ve realized this already, right? This is my message to you.”

Yes, this was Lloyd’s dying message, done in anticipation that his past self would utilize the Ending Spoiler, but something was off here.

I’m just smashed and feeling a little under the weather. How’s this my dying moment?

The future Lloyd seemed agitated and disheartened due to the hangover. But not near death.

Then, why is he acting like he's going to die... It couldn't possibly be...

"Correct. The Ending Spoiler shows the final moment of my life. And death can come in many ways," Future Lloyd grinned in that instant.

It couldn't be, Lloyd thought to himself. But his fear was proven correct.

Future Lloyd turned his head for the first time and spoke to Javier. "Now, Javier."

"Do we really have to do this...?" mumbled Javier, who was visibly distressed.

"Yes. This is the only way to save me, my parents, and the queen."

"But-"

"Trust me."

Lloyd could see from Javier's expression that the two had a lengthy debate about this and that he had stubbornly argued again and again with the knight for him to follow his plan. Javier nodded, tearing up. "Yes... Young Master."

Javier stood up, blocking the sun with his back, his features shadowed and his blade the only object gleaming in the sunlight.

Swish. Javier raised his sword. The end of the sword's blade was trembling. "Is this the only option we have left?" He asked again, seemingly confirming Lloyd's answer for the last time, or perhaps, unable to let go of his lingering hope.

"Yes."

"..."

Javier bit his lips.

Future Lloyd smiled bitterly, and as an afterthought, “Oh, after some thinking, I concluded that someone hastened the speed of the restoration of destiny. And that is...”

Lloyd watched the blood spurt in the air as Javier’s sword solemnly fell down and sliced through his body. He also heard the last words his future self said as his consciousness faded.

“Hell’s King...”

Everything went dark.

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Chapter 365: Karma (1)

“Hell’s King...”

Those were Lloyd’s last words, and they reflected his desperate desire to share what he had gone through.

Fwoosh! Lloyd’s vision went blank, and he felt as if his entire body was floating in the air before his eyes popped open.

“...”

Lloyd squirmed and looked around as the sound of crickets crying beneath the moonlit sky washed over him. The sitting room was peaceful, and the curtain he had seen earlier was dancing to the breeze coming in through the partially open window.

The Ending Spoiler is over.

Noticing how hard he was breathing, Lloyd relaxed on the sofa, loosened his body, and went over everything he saw and heard in the Ending Spoiler.

It was a direct message from my future self.

Lloyd instantly felt satisfied with himself for not losing his rationality even when all hell broke loose and the restoration of destiny came sooner than expected. His future self left a message with a clear overview of his experience. Then, he commanded Javier to slash him with a sword. It was his intention to die.

He needed to die at that exact moment for me to get the words he said right before then through the ending spoiler. It was a calculated act.

What a determined man he was, Lloyd reflected, but now was not the time to praise himself. Now was the moment to reflect on the wealth of information he had gathered from his future self.

Hell's King is the one who accelerated the restoration of destiny?

Lloyd couldn't know exactly why the king would do that. But he had a rough guess.

If it's the King of Hell, it's simple to deduce his reasoning. I must have tampered with the flow of time from how often I used my Time Freeze skill.

The Time Freeze skill was a trick Lloyd gladly took advantage of, especially when he was working on large-scale constructions. He also used it to delay the start of the restoration of destiny as well.

But the Hell's King wasn't happy about that.

It seemed plausible since it was undeniably true that freezing time to postpone the restoration of destiny was technically cheating. Lloyd figured that Hell's King wouldn't let that slide, given the latter's strait-laced character.

My future self must have glossed over the reason Hell's King accelerated the whole affair as he knew I would be able to figure that out on my own. I'm certain of it. I would have done the same thing. Besides, he likely didn't have enough time to explain every little detail.

Based on his experiences, the Ending Spoiler only showed a few minutes of the future. So, he would need to focus on a few key points and take out anything that was self-explanatory or unnecessary to deliver as much information as possible in that short time frame.

That's why I was told only about what happened to the queen, the count, and the countess.

As Lloyd continued to think, the situation started to piece itself together.

I suppose this new, accelerated version of the phenomenon is the second restoration of destiny. This time, the trigger was the amputation of the queen's left arm. The trigger for the first version of the restoration of destiny was the horse accident with Count Frontera.

In the initial version, the whole situation began after Count Frontera fell from his horse. That set off a series of terrible mishaps involving the death or crippling of many people in The Knight of Blood and Iron. However, in the second version...

It began with her left arm. I have to stop it, then.

After she lost her left arm, the queen would turn into a tyrant and wage war against his family. In the process, the count and countess would be killed.

If the story proceeds as it is, Julian, Scheherazade, the sultan, Orc Arosh, the two loan sharks, and I will all experience some sort of misfortune aligned with the new version of the phenomenon.

But if he could protect the queen's left arm? If she didn't lose her left arm?

She won't become a tyrant and start a civil war.

The story would develop differently. The count and countess wouldn't lose their lives. Of course, Lloyd knew the restoration of destiny wouldn't be put to a stop even then.

That's obvious. Dragon King Verkis warned me about it last time. No matter how many events I prevent, there will be more accidents and tragedies that come about in new ways. That is why my future self didn't choose to inform me about anything else.

Lloyd was able to understand the intent of his future self, who had delivered him a message through his will. First and foremost, the queen's left arm had to be safeguarded since it was the trigger for the second restoration of destiny. Afterward, a third version of the phenomenon would appear, and he would need to find the new trigger.

So, you're saying that's why it would be useless to inform me about anything else.

That was Lloyd's final conclusion. First, he would need to prevent the queen's left arm from becoming paralyzed and start decaying.

But there's something else I have to take care of before then.

Lloyd got up and moved to the bedroom adjacent to the sitting room. He then woke Javier up.

"Wakey-wakey."

"..."

"I'm relieved to see one try was enough to wake you up."

"I am a light sleeper. What is going on, Young Master?" replied Javier in confusion.

"Isn't it obvious? I woke you up because we have somewhere to go," said Lloyd.

"Where?"

"To Hell."

Javier turned and lay back to bed.

"Hey, why are you lying down again?"

"I would like for you to just be thankful that I am calmly returning to bed without a fight, Master Lloyd."

"Wow. Were you planning to hit me?"

"That is an obvious question."

"Tsk. Get up anyway."

"Why are we going to Hell again?"

"There's something I need to confirm."

"..."

Javier had a glow in his eyes. He wasn't asleep in the first place. He was rather listening from his bed from the time Lloyd vanished until the latter returned to mull over the situation in the sitting room. As a result, he felt compelled to ask Lloyd what was going on and what was bothering him so much.

Are you finally planning to share your concerns with me?

Javier asked himself as he rose and looked at Lloyd. His wish must have come true. The words he had been waiting to hear came out of Lloyd's mouth.

"To be honest, I do have a concern."

"..."

"The restoration of destiny will likely begin much earlier than expected and manifest in a different way as well."

"Are you sure?"

"Yeah. I'm sure." Lloyd nodded and proceeded to explain everything about the new turn of events, skipping the parts that involved his real identity and the Javier-or-Lloyd dilemma.

"If what you said is true... Her Majesty's left arm will start to decay, and the count and countess will be in danger."

"Yeah. Somewhat."

"When and where did you find out about this?" asked Javier.

"While I met with the queen earlier, something was odd about the movement in her left arm. So, I questioned her, and she indirectly admitted that it was paralyzed."

"And as for-"

“How did I predict the events that follow?” interrupted Lloyd. “I saw everything in a dream. It felt like some sort of premonition.” Lloyd changed the Ending Spoiler into a dream, the same way he did when he first explained the phenomenon to Count and Countess Frontera. To his relief, Javier remained silent instead of casting doubts, so Lloyd went on, “Of course, I’m not acting solely based on a silly dream. But what I saw was too real. It has made me nervous. I need to confirm it myself.”

“With Hell’s King?”

“Yes,” said Lloyd. “If my dream is right, the Hell’s King is responsible for why the restoration of destiny is happening earlier than anticipated. He has a problem with how I freezed the flow of time.”

“You wish to confirm the matter by confronting the most likely suspect.”

“That’s the plan.” Lloyd nodded. The thing was, he could have consulted the Jewel of Truth. But in this case, he wanted to confront Hell’s King.

I want to see with my own eyes what he wants from this. And if I can... I should negotiate.

He wanted to meet the king directly and see his chances of delaying the destiny restoration phenomenon.

“Anyhow, we need to move fast. Get out of bed. There isn’t even time for you to wash your face.”

Lloyd remembered what his future self said. The queen’s left arm was already decaying two months after it became paralyzed. As such, he didn’t have time to hesitate or waste too much on meeting with the King of Hell. Ten minutes later, they were ready to leave.

“Let’s go!” After urging Draggy to fly as fast as possible, they reached the North Pole in a matter of hours. Upon spotting the entrance to Hell, Lloyd exclaimed, “Throw us in, Draggy!”

Boom! Both of them broke through the blast of snow that covered the gate, and when they persevered and reached Hell, a fierce heat surged toward them.

“Whoa!”

Lloyd immediately searched his inner pocket and brought Ggoming out, who was already on standby.

“Hey, it’s your turn now.”

Lloyd held out the red sunflower seed. Ggoming ate it and became huge in an instant. He fluttered his giant wings and carried Lloyd and Javier, freefalling into the pit of ash.

“Ggoming! To Hell Castle!”

“Ggoming!” exclaimed Ggoming.

It had been a long time since Lloyd last breathed the musty air of Hell. They flew for a seemingly endless amount of time through the hazy heat and landed on the ground when the castle finally came into view. Upon landing, a large group of demons greeted Lloyd, making him feel like a celebrity at an airport. However, he was too busy to say hello to everyone.

“Run!”

Lloyd and Javier forcefully made their way through the cheering demons to King of Hell’s office. They stood in front of the massive desk in the room, where Hell’s King looked to be no different than when they last met him.

Scribble! Scribble! Scribble! The king’s throne was as plain as an office chair. His massive desk didn’t have a single decoration on it but was completely buried under paper. And surrounded by the paper piles, there was someone who looked like they were on the verge of death from being overworked. It was the King of Hell. He briefly glanced at Lloyd and proceeded to ignore him. The only thing he was focused on was the paper

piles surrounding him. While writing his signature down one after another at a rapid pace, he muttered a complaint.

“Can’t you see that I’m swamped right now? Tell me what you want. Make it quick,” grumbled the king as he signed off the papers.

Lloyd felt glad that the king was busy and willing to jump into business straight away. He said, “It has been a while, the ruler of karma and overlord of 19 purgatories. I, Lloyd Frontera, would like to dare ask you a question.”

“Ask what?”

“Did you accelerate the arrival of the restoration of destiny?”

“Yes, I did.”

Scribble! Hell’s King carelessly answered the query with a faint and uninterested nod as he continued to sign off papers at rapid speed, and Lloyd bit his lips at the sight, plainly upset by the lack of seriousness in a situation that may ruin his own life.

“May I ask why you did that?” asked Lloyd, suppressing his emotions.

“I certainly can,” Hell’s King said, his attention now fixated on Lloyd. “It is a very simple reason,” he added, flashing a huge smile as if he was looking at a pot of gold. “I want you, Suho Kim. You are the perfect talent for Hell.”

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Chapter 366: Karma (2)

“Suho Kim. I want you. You are the perfect talent for Hell.”

Swick! With a broad smile, the King of Hell flicked his finger. A wave of mana surrounded Javier, who was standing next to Lloyd.

Flinch! Lloyd noticed Javier’s shoulders faintly tremble and wondered if he had been attacked. Javier, however, shook his head and whispered in a low voice, “I have not been attacked, Young Master. But I cannot hear anything. It appears that he somehow blocked my hearing.”

Just when Lloyd was about to ask the king why, the latter let out a low snort and said, “You should thank me, Suho Kim. The secrets you have been hiding will be brought up several times throughout our discussion from now on.”

“Is that why you blocked his hearing?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, but it will only be for a short while.”

“How gracious of you,” huffed Lloyd.

“You are being quite short with me.”

“I don’t like to speak more than I have to at work.”

“The same is true for me, Suho,” the king of Hell replied mildly. “You are the most incredible talent that I have ever seen. By this, I mean you have all the necessary skills to manage Hell. That is why I decided to provide an excellent position for you here.”

Lloyd frowned. “Are you thinking of slaving me around in Hell?”

“Yes, I am.”

“So, that is why you made the restoration of destiny begin earlier?”

“That is also right.”

Lloyd shot him a glare.

“There is no need for that. This place is much better fitting for you to show off your skills. I’m giving you an opportunity to expand your horizon.”

Lloyd frowned again. “I never wanted that.”

“But I do,” replied Hell’s King instantly. “I want you to showcase your skills in Hell. I want to see you do great work on my behalf. That way I can-”

“Sit back and relax. Am I wrong?”

“No, you are correct,” the king said with a smile, not denying any of it. “The fact is, I am exhausted. However, it has been impossible for me to escape my fate as the King of Hell. That had always been the case and I didn’t think anything would change in the future. Right when I was about to give up, you showed up. The ideal candidate to take over my position: someone with the perfect balance of intelligence, righteousness, and greed.”

“To put it short, someone you can make use of.”

“Correct. I needed someone who could be entrusted with the affairs of Hell. I didn’t think that kind of talent could even exist despite my hopes.”

Lloyd clenched his fists and pursed his lips. It was now clear to him what intentions the king had and why he wanted to recruit him so badly.

His opinion of me is far too high. He wants to keep his title as the King of Hell while pushing all of his work onto me.

Lloyd was dumbfounded by the king’s words.

Does he think I worked my ass off all these years just to become his little puppet?

Lloyd immediately felt an impulse to confront the King of Hell, but realized it was not the right time. There was still plenty of room for negotiation before that needed to happen. So he suppressed it and replied, “Haah... I fully understand what you are saying. I am flattered by your high opinion of me. But I have a question.”

“A question?”

“Yes,” said Lloyd. “I am curious why you’re doing it now of all times.”

“Are you asking why I hastened the restoration of destiny?” asked the king.

“Yes. You could have just waited a few more decades to make use of me since I will inevitably die of old age. I can’t wrap my head around why you’re going so far to ruin my life and that of everyone around me.”

He truly wanted to know. That was the only way he could attempt a negotiation and have any possibility of hope to improve the situation. He waited for a response from the King.

“Now is my only chance,” said the King of Hell.

“Excuse me?”

“I mean tying you, Suho Kim, down to Hell.”

Lloyd didn’t follow.

“Suho Kim,” continued the king. “You have tricked and taken advantage of a fair number of people, putting them in awfully miserable positions at times. I would be surprised if you were not self-aware of this. Am I wrong?”

“That’s either because they harmed me first, or I had no other choice-”

“That is an excuse. You have plenty of them. You had a crumbling family to save. You had a life to build. You needed to protect what was yours. There is always an explanation for every act of evil. Amongst them, some are valid and some are not.”

“...”

“Your actions are the same, Suho. You had valid reasons for your bad deeds. However, they could have been avoided without a doubt, which is why you have accumulated bad karma.” Hell’s King’s eyes shone as he spoke. “Yes, bad karma. You have earned plenty of it now, enough for me to tie you down to Hell. However, once you start living a plush life full of peace and leisure, the situation will change.”

“Change? Could you mean-”

“That is right. As expected, you catch on quickly. I can tell that you are a good-natured man, Suho. You have merely been forced by unfortunate circumstances to take advantage of your surroundings for survival. But once you find peace in life, you will spend the rest of your remaining time taking care of everyone around you. Then, you will gradually earn good karma.”

“That’s what you feared would happen?”

“I was worried.”

“...”

“With your extended life from the sponsorship of Dragon King Verkis and naturally good character, all the bad karma you have accumulated will be erased, by which point I will not be able to make you stay in Hell.”

“In other words,” sighed Lloyd, “You made the restoration of destiny begin earlier so that I would not have time to earn good karma.”

“That’s right.”

“Ha.” A chuckle escaped Lloyd. The whole situation seemed ridiculous. Feeling obstinate, he asked, “Did you really believe I would die once the restoration of destiny began? Unfortunately, I don’t think I will.”

“Hmm, why is that?”

“What if I stubbornly choose to continue living even after everyone around me dies?”

“Ha! Do you really think I have not considered that possibility?” Hell’s King leaned forward. The eyes behind his rimless glasses were emotionless. “Suho Kim, there is no chance you will survive amidst the restoration of destiny. Why? This world does not want that to happen. It regards the man beside you, Javier, as its rightful protagonist.”

“...”

“As a result, you will face endless waves of hardship. Even if you manage to overcome them, you will only be met with greater ordeals.”

“...”

“These waves will only get worse as they come in. That is just how this phenomenon works. The more you overcome, the greater the next challenge will be. And so, it will mercilessly haunt you.”

“...”

“Are you then still confident that you will be able to stand strong until the end?”

“...”

Lloyd was unable to respond to this and had no ideas to counter the king, but he persisted nonetheless, saying, “Of course, I am not confident. But...”

“But?”

“I’d like for you to clarify one thing. If I promise to work for Hell in the future... Could you put a stop to the restoration of destiny?” Lloyd asked, pinning all his hopes on this question. He desperately wondered if he could save the Count, Countess, Julian, Scheherazade, and everyone else around him by promising, no, signing a contract to diligently work in Hell after death, in exchange for stopping the restoration of destiny.

Hell’s King clicked his tongue. “I did make the right judgment about your character. You are a good man at heart. But unfortunately, that is not possible.”

“Even... if I promise you?”

“No.” Hell’s King gravely shook his head, saying, “No, the restoration of destiny cannot be stopped once it has begun regardless of anyone’s opinion, including mine. The phenomenon can think and act for itself. It will not stop until it meets its goals.

“It reminds me of a computer program,” said Lloyd.

“Yes. It’s similar to a computer program of your world.”

“...”

“It must be clear to you by now. It’s out of my control,” said Hell’s King with finality in his voice.

“I see.” It was not a lie. The fact was painfully clear to him. The matter was beyond the King of Hell’s control.

If the restoration of destiny is a computer program... then the King of Hell is the programmer.

That was it. There was currently a program that couldn’t be paused once it began running. The programmer behind it, the King of Hell, claimed he had no control over it. Consequently, even if Lloyd killed the programmer, it would not affect the autonomous program.

In order to stop it... I need to either turn off its power source or break the machine itself.

Lloyd felt frustrated as he pondered a solution. As lost as he was, one thing was clear. He looked up and said, “There is no point in continuing this conversation then. It will only be a waste of our time.”

“It is. The restoration of destiny will continue progressing even if you attack or kill me, bluntly speaking.”

“I knew it...”

That confirmed his thoughts. A conversation or confrontation between them was pointless. Obviously, a negotiation wasn’t possible either. It was never an option to begin with.

Tsk, I was hoping I could ask to delay the restoration of destiny.

Lloyd pressed his lips. The reason he came all the way down to Hell was to negotiate with the king and ultimately request him to delay the restoration of destiny. He hoped this would earn him a bit more time. However, it turned out that there was no way to slow or stop the phenomenon once it began. What was he going to do from here?

I should end our conversation now.

“I see,” replied Lloyd immediately. “I will take my leave now.”

“Hmm. You are giving up too quickly.”

“I decided it would be better to take action instead of wasting time on this sort of conversation.”

“Are you saying you won’t give up?” asked the king in surprise.

“I should try my best to survive like I have until now.”

“It won’t be easy this time,” added Hell’s King.

“There wasn’t a single time it was easy.”

“Well, then. I wish you good luck.”

Swick! Hell’s King smiled mysteriously and flicked his finger. The same force of mana from earlier spread into the air and wrapped around Javier.

“Haah...” Javier let out a sigh.

Had his hearing returned?

The knight turned his head toward Lloyd and nodded, as though assuring Lloyd that he was all right.

“Good, that’s a relief.” Lloyd nodded his head. He then left the castle after bidding a proper farewell, clenching his teeth as he did.

Dammit. That worthless King of Hell!

The more Lloyd pondered the matter, the more infuriated he became. He knew that the King of Hell had thought highly of him and wanted to employ him. However, it had never occurred to him that the latter would go as far as to use the restoration of destiny to get what he wanted.

What’s worse is that he is justified in his actions. After all, I changed the fate of countless lives, starting from Count and Countess Frontera, as well as Javier.

The people who should have died lived, changing the list of names on the King of Hell’s registry. This gave the king a sufficient excuse to use the restoration of destiny as a way to rectify the situation.

What should I do now?

Lloyd sighed deeply as he glanced at the gloomy sky of Hell. His future seemed grim despite his confident declaration back in the castle.

What do I do?

He closed his eyes. Despite the dark future ahead of him, he tried to gather his emotions and not let himself become overwhelmed with despair.

Right. My life has never been easy.

After some introspection, he realized that was really the case. Back in South Korea, he had seen his parents commit suicide and afterward continued

living as a poor college student. There were at least a hundred times when he could have given up. He was hardly treated as a human being and resided at the bottom of society. That did not change when he arrived in this world. He had faced many obstacles and life-threatening moments up to this point. As he looked back on his experiences, he slowly started to gain courage.

All right. Let's face this head-on like I've done with everything else until now. If I fail? Well. I will just die then.

He felt more at ease having that kind of mindset to begin with. His scattered mind started to come together again. From that point on, he deliberated over what he could do and the paths he could take. Lloyd considered every variable and what changes they would bring. All the separate pieces came together like a puzzle. Everything unfolded like a crumpled piece of paper. The bleak future ahead of him became brighter. At last, he saw a glimmer of hope.

That's it.

Lloyd lifted his gaze to the sky. His eyes brightly gleamed like someone who saw the light at the end of their tunnel.

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Chapter 367: How to Redo an Underdrawing (1)

That's it.

Lloyd saw a faint ray of hope. It wasn't anything significant. However, it was enough to overcome his current situation.

I shouldn't try to solve everything right away, especially with important matters like this.

One thing at a time, as if he was untangling a ball of yarn.

The first thing I need to do is take care of the trigger for the second version of the restoration of destiny.

This was something that had been on his mind. Once he took care of the trigger and stopped the restoration of destiny...

Then, the third and fourth versions of the phenomenon will likely begin one after another.

But Lloyd didn't care. Each version of the restoration of destiny would come with a trigger that sparked its beginning.

I just need to stop the event that acts as the trigger.

That way, he'd be able to put a stop before the situation took a serious turn and took everyone's lives.

I know it's not a permanent solution. But it will buy me more time. That is good enough.

He needed to stop the trigger and the restoration destiny with it. If he had to, he would use his Time Freeze skill to buy more time and figure out the answer to the dilemma of choosing his or Javier's life. The more he thought about it, the more confident he felt.

It's doable. I also have a way to stop her paralysis.

Lloyd gave a small smile and looked at Javier, who was sitting alongside him on Ggoming, before asking, “How about we teach the Asrahan Core Technique to the queen?”

“Come again?” Javier retorted in mild disbelief.

Lloyd chuckled. “I’m thinking of teaching her the Asrahan Core Technique. But since we created the technique together, I wanted to hear your opinion first.”

“Teach her the Asrahan Core Technique?” Javier chuckled as if the suggestion wasn’t making any sense. “Master Lloyd, you do know how tedious and difficult it is for a knight to master a mana utilization technique, right?”

“Of course.”

“If you’re asking me while fully knowing that, it means your conversation with the King of Hell did not go well.”

“Thanks for catching on quickly.”

“Is that what you finally came up with? Teaching her the Asrahan Core Technique?”

“Um, maybe.”

“Anyhow, I have a question.”

“What is it?” Lloyd looked at Javier.

“What did you talk about with the king?”

“Are you interested?”

“A little bit,” Javier confessed. Lloyd noticed how sincere his eyes were.

I can tell he’s not just curious. He genuinely wants to help.

Lloyd pondered if it was for his family, himself, or both. Lloyd smiled. “The King of Hell and I...” Lloyd then repeated their conversation to Javier, keeping just two aspects of it hidden: his real name, Suho Kim, and the truth about the restoration of destiny.

I can never tell Javier that this world is fictional, everything’s happening because I took away his role as the original protagonist, and the only way to completely get out of this situation would be for one of us to die...

Lloyd could not tell him. Was it because he feared Javier would hurt him? No, it was the opposite. If he found out, Javier would immediately commit suicide to rescue Lloyd and his family. That could never happen. Their world was inside *The Knight of Blood and Iron* for crying out loud. But more than anything else, he would miss the reliable presence of this knight who always stood by his side to protect him. But even without these practical reasons...

I don’t want that.

Javier had already become his best friend. There was no one else he would be able to trust as much as him even if they always bickered with each other. Lloyd refused to lose him before he could even find another solution. That was why he revealed the discussion with the King of Hell, including the latter’s decision to make the restoration of destiny begin earlier, how it was now unstoppable, and how the triggers for the phenomenon needed to be dealt with. He didn’t hide anything besides the cause of the phenomenon.

“That is how you came up with the idea of using the Asrahan Core Technique as a way the treat the queen’s left arm,” observed Javier after hearing the whole story.

“You’re right,” agreed Lloyd.

“Hmm.”

“What? Do you not like it?” asked Lloyd.

“No, I am concerned. You should know that she has no chance of properly learning the Asrahan Core Technique.”

“Yeah, I know,” said Lloyd as he nodded, feeling the hot air in the sky. He knew it well. Of course. “The Asrahan Core Technique is a specialized skill for mana absorption, circulation, and discharge. That means she will have to relearn all of her skills. Her mana circulation system and mana circle will need to be restructured.”

It was true. The process of learning the the technique was developing the foundation of a mana circulation system. It was the same for Lloyd when he first started learning it.

It was easy for me since I was a complete novice at the time without a manaheart. If I were a painting, I would be a blank piece of white paper.

That made the job a lot easier, and he was able to learn the technique without much struggle. But Javier had a difficult time as he was a high-level sword expert.

The process was a lot harder for him than me since he had to unlearn everything and start from scratch. It was comparable to trying to change the underdrawing of a nearly finished painting. Honestly, it was at an impossible level of difficulty.

But Javier did it. There was no grand secret behind his success.

He’s a genius swordsman that will be remembered in history. Tsk.

This was the reason people were afraid of geniuses. The knight could perform feats that would be impossible for anyone else as if they were nothing. When it came to swordsmanship and its related subjects, Javier was a genius or perhaps a monster.

But the queen is different. Without a doubt, she’s an excellent swordswoman. But she’s not quite as brilliant as Javier.

Moreover, Queen Alicia had already become a swordmaster a long time ago. To give an analogy, she was akin to a perfectly finished painting that had been put into a frame. For her to learn the Asrahan Core Technique, it would be no different than having to redo her entire underdrawing while not damaging the finished painting within the borders of her frame.

The chance of success would be one in a million, close to impossible. Her circumstances made it far more difficult for her to learn the technique than Javier, and she was considerably less talented than him.

“I suppose you have a plan in mind, given that you will continue moving forward despite being aware of this,” said Javier.

“Somewhat,” Lloyd said, pleased that Javier could understand him without any lengthy explanation. It must have been the time the two spent together. “Your guess is correct. It will be a tedious process, but one that’s worth trying.”

“I see.” Javier nodded. “Let us do it your way, Young Master.”

“Really? Are you sure you won’t be upset?”

“Yeah, I am fine.” Javier turned and faintly smiled at Lloyd. “In the first place, we both made it together, so it is not just mine to begin with. You have joint rights to it, Master Lloyd. And...”

“And?”

“I know that you are not suggesting this for your personal gain.”

“Hmm.”

“I know that you are doing it for the lord, your family, and everyone else that’s involved. I know that you are acting this way, knowing you will sometimes appear selfish and be criticized as sly or manipulative.

“Hmm...”

“I will trust you, Master Lloyd. Please act on your plan if you have something in mind. I will help you to the best of my abilities.”

“Hmm...”

“Master Lloyd...?” asked Javier.

“Yeah.”

“Why are you giving me that strange look?”

“Oh, I was just wondering how you can manage to be this cheesy.”

“...”

“Be honest. You aren’t Javier, right? The Javier that I know would never compliment me so openly. He thoroughly enjoys chewing me up and spitting me out. At the very least, he isn’t someone who would suck up to me.”

“...”

“If not, did you secretly invest in stocks? Or did you buy betcoins and lose money on it?

“I do not know about the stocks, betcoin, or whatever it was. But...”

“But what?”

“I never expected to regret what I said so soon.”

“Right?”

“Yes, truly.”

“See? There was no need for the toe-curling words.”

Javier’s brows furrowed after his first defeat in a long time.

A mischievous smile appeared on Lloyd’s mouth. “Anyway, I know that you’re willing to help, so I’ll carry out my plan. Although, I’m strictly doing this for personal gain and not the greater good.”

“Is that so...?”

“Uh-huh. Of course.” Lloyd nodded. “Think about it. No one in this world is happy about sacrificing their life for someone else. I’m not a saint. I’m just doing this to live a peaceful life of absolute leisure.”

He was only half-serious about it. He was not anyone great like a police officer, firefighter, or another brave citizen who willingly risked their lives for others. He was just a normal person who wanted to become rich and have a long, normal life in good health. An ordinary man whose goal was to live a luxurious and hearty life. Although he didn’t want to cause harm to anyone, he didn’t want to save countless people, bravely sacrifice himself, pledge himself to the greater good, or act like he was a hero in any other way. The thought of it made his toes curl and sent a chill down his spine.

That’s not the kind of person I am. Honestly, it makes me feel guilty to embellish myself that way.

Lloyd shook off his chills. “So, it’s decided. We’re going to teach her the Asrahan Core Technique.”

Fwoosh! Lloyd then encouraged Ggoming to fly faster, and when they arrived at the Hell gate connected to the North Pole, they entered and felt the biting coldness. There, they hopped on Draggy’s back. “To the south!”

The flight path changed to the south, across the North Pole sea, enormous range, woodlands, farmland, and cities, until they arrived at the capital, when Lloyd immediately entered the palace and demanded an audience with the queen.

“Hmm... It appears we meet quite frequently these days.”

“Hahaha, don’t we?”

Lloyd was greeted with a grin from Lord Chamberlain as if he were the man's regular customer for business. His request for an audience was quickly granted, and he was taken to the queen's office.

"I, Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera County, am honored to be in the audience of the rightful owner of this land."

Queen Magentano, who was reviewing the report in her office, chuckled and replied, "You are here again, Lloyd Frontera."

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"I wonder what you want from me this time." Her voice sounded reproachful and seemed to demand Lloyd to get straight to the point about whatever it was that he wanted.

Lloyd smiled bitterly and revealed, "Yes, Your Majesty. But this time, I came for a matter about you, not me."

"For me?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"Interesting. Go on."

"I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty. I have found a way to treat your left arm."

"My left arm?" Her face froze.

Lloyd nodded nonchalantly. "Yes, Your Majesty. But..."

"But what?"

"There is one tedious element with the treatment I found, which you have to shoulder."

"What could that tedious thing be?"

“Do I have your permission to tell you?”

“Tell me.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd lowered his head again. Their conversation from here on out was what really mattered. The surefire way for Queen Magentano to overcome the impossible and perfect the Asrahan Core Technique. “Please forgive me for what I am about to say, but you will have to be stuck with me for every minute of the next two months.”

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Chapter 368: How to Redo an Underdrawing (2)

“Please forgive me for what I am about to say, but you have to be stuck with me for every minute of the next two months.”

Lloyd’s sharp and straightforward response silenced Queen Magentano. For a brief moment, she considered hitting his head with an ink bottle or dislocating his jaw with her bare hands. However, she quickly simmered down.

This is the kind of person he is. A madman who spouts nonsense without a second thought.

That was how it had always been until now. His ideas seemed like insanity at first glance, but they frequently turned out to be genius in the long run. It was a mischievous quirk that was unique to Lloyd.

“Ha. Seriously...” A chuckle escaped her. “You are saying I have to spend the entirety of the next two months with you?”

“Yes, that is true, Your Majesty.”

“If I do, you say my left arm will heal.” Her voice dripped with doubt.

“That will likely be the case, Your Majesty.”

“Likely?” She frowned. “You are not sure yet.”

“The matter at hand is not something I can dare make any promises about, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd.

“That sounds like you’re saying it’s nothing more than a possibility.”

“Even so, we should grasp at whatever possibility within our reach,” Lloyd said, his voice growing serious in response to her question. Possibility. Yes, they had to grasp onto it. At the very least, their attempt would allow them to confirm if it was an illusion or something more. It was especially

important to make an effort during times like now when there was not a single other option in sight.

From what I observed in the Ending Spoiler, the queen tried all sorts of different things when she realized her left arm was paralyzed and starting to decay. However, it all failed.

Lloyd had to step in as the palace and the queen herself were unable to find a remedy for her condition. In a way, he was the only possible hope they had.

I have to convince her.

He knew failure to persuade her would lead to the loss of her arm and fall from grace. Keeping this in mind, he carefully chose his words as he started to speak again.

“I am sure you remember the time when I was frantically absorbing mana.”

“Hmm. Of course, I remember. I do not often go through such a horrific experience.”

“...”

“Relax. It is all in the past, and you saved me in the end. Anyhow, am I right to suppose this must have something to do with your suggestion?” asked Queen Magentano gently.

“Absolutely, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“Are you possibly planning to absorb my mana like that time?”

“It is the opposite, Your Majesty.” Lloyd found it easy to talk to Alicia as the latter was always quick to catch on just like now. She swiftly understood his intentions without the need for long, flowery explanations. Lloyd politely lowered his head. “As a matter of fact, the mana utilization method I used then is called the Asrahan Core Technique.”

“The Asrahan Core Technique?” repeated the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty. As you can tell from its name, the technique was created by Sir Javier Asrahan, and I gave him a little help with perfecting it at the end.”

“Hmm. Interesting. A technique that led to the birth of a grandmaster and swordmaster.” Her eyes lit up the moment Lloyd began to talk about the technique. She was truly born to be a swordswoman.

Suppressing the smile on his lips, he said, “Yes, Your Majesty. That technique is what allowed me and Sir Asrahan to become who we are today.”

“What is so special about it?”

“It specializes in the absorption, processing, circulation, and discharging of mana.”

“Just like when you were absorbing my mana before?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd sensed that he had attracted her attention. Now, it was time to get straight to the main point. “That made me dare have the thought of teaching the Asrahan Core Technique to you.”

“You want to teach me that technique?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Do you think it will cure my left arm?” she asked, genuinely curious.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Good. Their conversation was flowing fairly nicely, Lloyd thought. “For the next two months, I will stay by your side every minute of every day. We’ll tie one of our hands together so I may continuously circulate my mana in your left arm.”

“Then?”

“Your symptoms will improve as mana begins to circulate in your arm again.”

“Are you certain?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“What comes next?” she asked.

“I will also teach you the Asrahan Core Technique.”

“That sounds like it’ll be difficult for me to learn.”

“I understand what you are saying, Your Majesty. You surely perfected your mana circulation system while becoming a swordmaster a long time ago. I know that it is nearly impossible to relearn such a foundational technique.”

“If that’s true, how can I learn the technique?” asked Queen Magentano.

“Through our bound hands, you will certainly be able to do so by having your body memorize the pathway of mana that I guide through it,” explained Lloyd.

“To put it another way, you will lay down the basic foundation for me to learn, but the rest is up to me.”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty,” Lloyd hung his head down. At the same time, he sensed something.

All right. I won her over.

Lloyd could feel that the queen was willing to take up the offer but slightly hesitant. Sometime later, she asked with a troubled face, “I see what you are proposing. It is extremely appealing. However, there is one thing bothering me.”

“If I may dare speak, could you be concerned about how the people around you may react, Your Majesty?”

“Indeed,” she said, a sad smile on her face. “As you know, I do not have a lover. That’s why people may… misunderstand our relationship if I spend two months stuck together day and night with a man, a subject of mine and a public official at that, whom I have not even promised a future with.”

“You are certainly right, Your Majesty.” Lloyd accepted the queen’s point. It was actually something Lloyd was worried about beforehand and undoubtedly needed to go over.

This would create a scandal for even an ordinary young noble lady. So, it goes without saying for Queen Alicia who’s the queen of the kingdom as her title suggests. She is probably completely against getting swept into such a scandal and becoming the subject of gossip.

It wouldn’t be a small scandal. It would directly affect the dignity of the queen herself. Lloyd, however, had a plan in mind. “Your Majesty, there is nothing to worry about.”

“It sounds like you have a plan in mind.”

“Absolutely, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“Tell me.”

“I do not doubt your excellent leadership, charisma, and governance. Furthermore, I have unwavering faith in your incredible political leadership and persuasion abilities. This is my source of hope and the plan I have in mind, Your Majesty,” Lloyd said as he bowed his head down.

“Tsk.” She clicked her tongue and muttered. “In summary, you are handing over the problem to me so that I can deal with it.”

“I am filled with gratitu... no, I mean, please forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“Are you truly sorry?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Haah. I might as well hammer a nail through your tongue...”

“Your Majesty?” gasped Lloyd.

“No, I was talking to myself.”

Lloyd did hear everything she said but chose not to respond, knowing that she would embrace his proposal and take care of any potential scandal on her own.

At last, she nodded. “I see.”

“That means...”

“I see how sly, irritating, and vile you are.”

“...”

“Besides that, I see your suggestion is not entirely bad, even if it comes with a bit of a scandal. I will also not deny that your help may be the one I need most at the moment.”

“So...” asked Lloyd again.

“I will accept your offer.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.” It was done. Lloyd felt relieved, so he bowed. “I shall now begin preparing for-”

“Prepare?” she asked sharply.

“Your Majesty?” Lloyd lifted his head in surprise and saw the mysterious smile on her face.

“We could start right away. Is there a need for a particularly grand preparation?”

“Uhm, that is because-”

“You said it yourself,” she said. “This is a good treatment method for my left arm. And so, there is no need for any additional preparation which

could lead to a delay. Am I wrong?”

“...”

Lloyd wanted to deny her words and say he needed some time to prepare. However, he couldn’t. She cocked her head to the side. “Is there a separate process that you have not told me about?”

“That is not true, but-”

“But what?”

“I am not mentally prepared...”

She gave him a stern look.

“Never mind, Your Majesty. I shall get right to it. Immediately.”

“Good,” she finally said with a smile. Lloyd broke out in a cold sweat at her eagerness. The situation was moving far faster than he had anticipated.

I thought she would be more embarrassed, resistant, or hesitant. So, I expected the queen to need a lot of coaxing to agree with my plan.

But what happened was the exact opposite of that. The queen was extremely eager to start treatment right away. In fact, she was urging him to move faster.

She gets a 10/10 in proactiveness. Wow.

Lloyd understood her proactive attitude after imagining how stressed she must have been about her left arm all alone without anyone to share her concerns with.

“Yes, Your Majesty. We can start right away,” said Lloyd.

“All right. Then, what should I do now?”

“First, we must bind our hands together like I have mentioned earlier.”

“My left hand and your right hand?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd swiftly examined the workplace for the leather strap used to bind paper bundles and said, “I will transfer mana into you through my bound hand.”

“Are you going to circulate the mana in my left arm?” guessed Queen Magentano.

“Yes, Your Majesty. At the same time, I will closely observe and analyze the circulatory pathway of mana that has already been finalized by you.”

She observed, “And based on your findings, you will find where the foundation for the Asrahan Core Technique can be established.”

“You are certainly right, Your Majesty.”

“It’s a similar process to surveying or developing a design, which are your specialties.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“I see. Begin immediately.”

“Yes, Your Majesty. May I...” Lloyd approached the queen, who extended her left hand in a slightly awkward manner. He could not tell if it was due to her paralysis or because she was feeling hesitant. He tried not to mind and extended his right hand. However, he flinched as their fingers touched before moving on to grab her entire hand, which was surprisingly warm.

“Why are you hesitating?” She blurted before clasping their hands tightly. “Tie it quickly.”

“Understood, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd then attempted to tie their hands, but doing so with his left hand proved so difficult that his mind went blank. This necessitated the

assistance of the queen’s right hand, and they were barely able to create a secure knot.

“I cannot believe how difficult this is. We should avoid untying ourselves unless it’s absolutely necessary,” she stated.

“I agree with you...” Lloyd was still dazed when he realized their hands were securely clasped together, his hand slightly numb. “I don’t have much blood circulating in my hand.”

“Is that uncomfortable for you?”

“Not at all, Your Majesty. However-”

“However what?”

“I was afraid that you might find it so.”

“I am fine. We must untie ourselves when we wash ourselves, use the bathroom, or change clothes anyway.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Then what is the problem?”

“Nothing at all, Your Majesty. I will start the treatment right away,” he said, his cheeks burning up because this method proved to be a million times more embarrassing than he had anticipated, and he was ready to act to alleviate the awkwardness when...

“Wait,” she said, pulling her left hand and interfering with the flow of mana going through it. Lloyd lifted his head to see what it was now and saw her smiling. “Before that, I just remembered a matter of grave importance that you must attend to tonight.”

“Your Majesty?”

“This way.” She jerked her left arm even harder, gaining entire control of Lloyd, who was flopped down on the office chair later.

“Your Majesty?”

“Shh...” She then sat on the chair beside it, dragged it forward, and leaned forward, bringing her face closer to Lloyd, who felt her breath for a split second and wondered if he needed to move back. Something was then inserted into his hand – a pen.

“Your Majesty?” Lloyd mumbled.

She stared at him with an intense gaze. “What is wrong? This can’t be your first time using a pen.”

“That is, of course-”

“Then, do as I say,” ordered Queen Magentano.

The amused smile on her face piqued Lloyd’s interest, and he found his heart racing as he watched her smile.

Have you lost your mind? Are you nuts? Get it together.

Lloyd fought hard to stay strong and locked to his goals, which were to date an ordinary girl and live a happy life with children. He struggled to not envision marrying the queen, going on a honeymoon, the number of children they would have, and so on...

“Okay, these are documents that require your signature, and that is mine,” Queen Magentano said.

Lloyd was jostled out of his trance with her piercing voice. He immediately woke up. “Your Majesty?” He then looked at her, who was directing her gaze on the pile of documents on the desk.

“Sign it,” she said.

“Your Majesty?”

“I said, sign it.”

This bundle of documents? An ominous feeling gripped Lloyd. His hunch turned out to be right.

Her playful smile grew wider. “Since you and I must stay together for a long period of time, I believe this will be very convenient. You will not say it is difficult just because you are signing it with your left hand, will you? My signature is very plain, as you can see.”

“Ah, um-”

“Sign everything.”

“All of these documents?” gasped Lloyd.

“Of course.”

“...”

“Do not even think about going to sleep before you finish.”

“...”

Lloyd inwardly begged to be spared from the chore, but it was futile. The night was long, and the documents were numerous. He signed them with his shaky left hand while the queen watched him with a glow of satisfaction that he could not tell was from making him do her work or seeing him struggle through it. In any case, the night was really far too long.

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Chapter 369: For Better or Worse (1)

A new morning arrived. Lloyd opened his bloodshot eyes.

“...”

His back ached, and his shoulders hurt. There was tension in his thigh, and his right hand felt numb. Well, he should have expected the pain.

I slept in this position on my stomach the whole night. Argh.

He could not lie down on the bed since his hand was tied to the queen’s, and lying down meant lying next to her on the same bed.

If I dared did that... it would only be right for me to be executed.

He was eventually forced to place a chair alongside the bed, with his legs and lower torso on the chair and his upper torso and right arm stretched on the bed, much like how he used to lie down in school. Naturally, he could not get much sleep.

I barely got any sleep.

He sighed again because sleeping in this posture was impossible, and to make matters worse, he had to keep injecting his own mana into her left arm as promised, which proved to be more difficult.

It’s a tough job to push my mana in her because Alicia’s manaheart is bigger than mine.

Mana, like water and air, flowed from areas of high pressure to areas of low pressure, and because her manaheart was larger than his, the pressure was higher and stronger, which meant Lloyd had to be careful how he injected mana into her left arm. Otherwise, the flow of mana reversed each time he lost concentration, and her mana traveled into his system.

I can’t let that happen. I have to continue giving her my mana. The mana needs to continuously circulate in the queen’s left arm even if it’s by force.

In other words, it was similar to a blood donation in that he had to supply as much mana as possible. So, Lloyd could not lose his focus and had to stay up the entire night to concentrate on the task, which explained his sleep deprivation.

“Did you not get a good night’s sleep either, Your Majesty?”

“Of course not,” she said, still laying on the bed, her head inclined toward his side, her eyes bloodshot like his, as if she had not gotten any sleep either. “I could not sleep because of you,” she muttered.

“Your Majesty?”

“Your body ran hot sometimes, only for it to turn cold, prickly, then uselessly soft.”

“Oh... um.”

“I meant my left arm,” she clarified. “My arm felt strange as it kept receiving your mana.”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“Forgive me, my foot,” she huffed.

“...”

“And how you moaned in pain all night! I considered asking if giving me mana was that exhausting of a job but decided against it since doing so might place more burden on you.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd.

“Gratitude, my foot.”

“...”

“How was your sleep?” she asked.

“That is...”

“You can be honest.”

“It was extremely uncomfortable, Your Majesty.”

“I knew it. You should have told me.”

“How could I-”

“Ask to lie on the same bed?” she interrupted first.

“...”

“I guess I am right. You should have asked,” she said with a chuckle.

Contrary to her nonchalance, Lloyd’s heart beat fast. “But Your Majesty, it is indecent-”

“Is it not indecent that you spent the night with me in the same bedroom already?”

“...”

“You have committed a grave crime of treason by spending last night alone with me, the queen. Did you not expect this when you proposed it to me?”

“I did,” confessed Lloyd.

“You did?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Then, why do you look so shy?”

“Ehem, I am in your presence in closed quarters.”

“You must have been embarrassed,” she said, finally understanding Lloyd.

“No, Your Majesty!”

“You must have been shy then.”

“Not at all, Your Majesty!”

“Really?”

“Of course, Your Majesty!” Lloyd argued firmly.

“Why do you dare to raise your voice in my presence then?”

“Ack...”

“Ha, I understand. I know how you feel. Seeing how you are denying my words so desperately, I can tell what you are thinking.”

“Your Majesty!”

“I will have the Lord Great Chamberlain prepare a makeshift bed for you, which will be placed beside mine, and you will feel less pressured because we will not be sharing a single bed.”

“W-Words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Majesty.”

“Tsk. How you only say that when you want something,” she mumbled as she turned to his side. Unlike her usual appearance, her hair was in a naturally disheveled state, her eyes toward him sparkled under the morning sunlight, and she was dressed comfortably.

“Um,” hurriedly uttered Lloyd. “I have to change my clothes now. I need to untie our hands, Your Majesty.”

“You should. The Lord Great Chamberlain will pass out if he ever finds us like this.”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd, “I believe the least we could do to prevent him from passing out is wearing our daily clothes.”

“I agree with you.”

When Lloyd loosened the rope, he discovered marks around his wrist. As he massaged his wrist, the queen walked across the enormous bedroom, and he soon heard the rustling noise of her changing clothing. “But I have a question for you.”

“Yes, Your Majesty?”

“Why you?” she asked.

“Your Majesty?”

“Why did you bind yourself with me instead of using Javier Asrahan? The question came to me last night when I was thinking to myself instead of sleeping. You said the Asrahan Core Technique was created by Sir Javier Asrahan, so I figured he must be far more adept in its use.”

“Yes, that is the case, Your Majesty.” Lloyd was quick to admit.

“He should be. Plus, he is a grandmaster.”

“You are certainly right, Your Majesty.”

“Then, why you?”

“Hmm, that is...” Lloyd stopped short of revealing the honest answer, which was that Javier was too gorgeous for this, but he disregarded it and said with a logical and sensible answer, “As Your Majesty knows, he is a genius in swordsmanship.”

“I am aware of that. He is not just any genius.”

“Yes, Your Majesty. I believe he is someone who will be remembered throughout history. That is the reason.”

“Is it because he is too much of a genius? Or because he cannot understand the perspective of an ordinary person?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd replied, nodding and speaking toward the partition where she was standing. “To him, the Asrahan Core Technique is as simple as breathing, which means he will not easily understand the challenges you and I will face. He will only wonder why we cannot do something so easy.”

“Ha. You are right. His perspective must be different from ours to begin with.”

“Truly yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd replied. Javier was the genius among the geniuses. It was only natural that he would not understand why she was having so much difficulty. To him, the entire job would be as simple and ordinary as drinking and eating. Any challenge she faced would be a mystery in his eyes.

“As such, I have been entrusted with this grave duty in place of Javier Asrahan.”

“Hmm.”

“Moreover, I judged that it is more advantageous for me to take the job as I devised the plan and would be allowed to judge the situation, given how significant the success is in this job.”

“Hmm...”

“Moreover, please forgive me for saying this, but I am more immune to the scandals that may arise,” explained Lloyd further.

“Hmm...”

“Your Majesty?”

“What?” she snapped.

“Why do you only ‘Hmm’ instead of saying more?”

“Nothing. I just happen to find your excuses to be pathetic.”

“Your Majesty?”

“Would it not be enough to say, ‘I just wanted to’?”

“Your Majesty...?”

“Answer me or we will spend the entire day training.”

“Yes, Your Majesty. I wanted to take this job. I wanted to be beside you more than he did. I am serious.”

“Tsk. Is that how much you hate our training?”

“...”

“Anyway, I understand how genuine your concern is for me. Come here then.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd walked to her side.

Now dressed in her usual clothes, she held out her hand. “Tie us now.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Tying their hands together proved to be extremely difficult once again. Right when he finished, the sound of a bell came from outside of the bedroom.

Cling. Cling. Two ringing noises came from outside the bedroom. “Your Majesty, the rightful owner of this kingdom, I am here to greet you in the morning.”

“Get in,” naturally answered Queen Magentano.

Lloyd imagined her giving the same reply every day. The bedroom door opened to let in the Lord Great Chamberlain and a group of maids to tidy her up for the day. But everyone froze.

“Your Majesty...?”

Lloyd noticed the shiver in the man’s lips and how the latter’s face gradually grew paler with each passing second.

“Y-Your Majesty!” The old man’s eyes moved in utter dismay. One glance at the queen. And the other one at Lloyd. He did it once again. One glance at the queen. And a glare at Lloyd.

“Ehem. Hmm!” Lloyd cleared his throat to act as natural as possible.

But Queen Magentano was utterly composed. “Why are you surprised?”

“Your... Majesty...” The great servant stuttered. “It is...”

“Are you surprised to find Lloyd Frontera with me so early in the morning?”

“That is...”

“Or are you shocked by the possibility that I seemed to have spent the night with him?”

“Th-That’s...”

“It is all right. Your guesses are right,” affirmed Queen Magentano.

“Y-Your Majesty!”

“Tsk,” she said. “Nothing that you are imagining happened. We are doing this for a good reason.”

Her reaction was even more unexpected than Lloyd had anticipated. She acted as though the entire matter were trivial and unimportant. “What is the big deal? Would you dare try to meddle in choosing my future spouse if we are what you think we are?”

“That is not true, but-”

“Yes, I know,” she said softly. “You must be concerned about the reputation and honor of the imperial family. Rest assured that this is nothing of the sort

that requires your concern.” She chuckled. “Do you see how our hands are tied? We are doing a special joint training together to pave a new path of swordsmanship.”

“I see that your hands are tied, Your Majesty,” replied Lord Great Chamberlain.

“That is the proof. As such, continue your daily business like you always have.”

“I am at your service, Your Majesty... Then... How do you wish to arrange the clothes and breakfast?”

“As you can see, I have finished dressing myself. I will come down for my meal. Oh, but I need help with my makeup.”

“At your service, Your Majesty.” The Lord Great Chamberlain hung his head, breaking out in a cold sweat. He seemed half-dazed by the unexpected scene.

Ha... I showed him something unsightly there.

Lloyd felt apologetic as he watched the old man hurry out.

“Oh, and one more thing.” Her voice stopped him short. “Tell the House of Peers that I will visit them soon.”

“Your Majesty?” The Lord Great Chamberlain’s eyes widened at the unexpected order.

She smiled at him. “Why are you surprised? Did you really think that we would just sneak around inside the palace like this?”

“Yes, Your Majesty, of course-”

“This is a part of our training, and I have no plans to hide it from anyone else,” she gravely announced.

“...”

“Just as you reacted, the House of Peers will seriously consider this training method between myself and Lloyd Frontera. As such, I shall pay them a visit and put an end to any of their suspicions in advance.” Her demeanor could not be more confident. It appeared to Lloyd that she was about to split open the head of anyone who opposed their relationship.

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Chapter 370: For Better or Worse (2)

“Um... Your Majesty...”

“Tell me,” said Queen Magentano.

“Please forgive me for saying this, but it looks like everyone is in deep shock.”

“They should be.” The corners of her lips rose.

Lloyd sighed and took in his surroundings. He noted the heavy silence in the conference room of the House of Peers. Despite that, the space was quite crowded with people, and it was difficult to spot any open seats. Everyone was packed inside like they were college students gathered in a classroom for a lecture from a popular professor.

Tsk. I always see the same sight every time I come. That is, the sight of everyone in a shocked state of silence.

Lloyd put on a wry smile as he could clearly relate to their expressions of complete bewilderment.

It’s understandable. Everyone would have assumed this was just another visit from the queen to discuss something with them.

They would have likely expected it to be a normal day. Her visit would have been nothing particularly special until she emerged with her hand tied to one of Lloyd’s.

I hope no one is going to frame me as a traitor who deserves to be killed.

Of course, no one would do that since they would likely be raising issues with the queen, not him. And his prediction was proven right a few seconds later.

“Y-your Majesty! What is this?” Duke Toscano, the first one to come to his senses, stuttered, breaking the heavy silence amongst the shocked nobles in the room.

She then replied, “I understand that all of you are terrified to find me and Lloyd Frontera like this. But there is nothing to be surprised.” In a more confident voice, she added, “I am informing you right now that we will spend the next two months tied together by our hands. However, this is nothing romantic and only a part of our training to pave a new path of sword mastery.”

After exchanging glances with the others, Duke Toscano finally said, “But Your Majesty,” as he wiped the perspiration from his face with a handkerchief. “Please forgive me for saying this, but the long-standing tradition and law of the kingdom dictate that an unmarried queen must follow proper formalities and procedures when choosing a partner-”

“Duke Toscano,” she growled as her eyes grew serious. “I did clearly mention that this is not an act of romance, did I not?”

“Oh...” Duke Toscano sealed his lips.

“Do you not trust my words?”

“That is certainly not the case, Your Majesty.”

She then observed the room. Her mouth eventually curved into a smile. “Did I go too far against common sense?” She, too, could understand the dismay on their faces. After all, she and Lloyd Frontera were not married. To anyone with common sense, the declaration to spend the next two months holding hands would be ill-received and interpreted as a behavior between a couple. Feeling the need to stress that this was just training, she emphasized, “I see what your concern is. Even if I say it is training, it will not be received the same way in the outside world. This is something you are worried about, correct?”

Duke Toscano was glad that she understood. “Your Majesty is truly wise. That is what we are worried about.”

“Are you also worried about the diminishing dignity and status of my royal house outside the country?” she asked again.

“Truly yes, Your Majesty,” replied Duke Toscano as he hung his head down. The other nobles looked like this concern was universal in this room.

But she simply chuckled. “Let them do so.”

“Your Majesty...?” Duke Toscano winced in surprise.

“Their worthless opinions do not matter to me because I believe that improving my sword skills is the only practical power to save my royal house. I could care less about how people outside my kingdom perceive me because they cannot interfere with my kingdom’s affairs.” She spoke in an adamant voice.

“But Your Majesty...” Duke Toscano stopped short before finishing.

“Do tell.”

“Words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Majesty. I fully understand your will. I have no inkling of doubt as well that your betterment will strengthen the prowess of this kingdom. But Lloyd Frontera is...”

“What about him?” she asked.

Duke Toscano stole a glance at Lloyd before speaking. “It is undeniable that he is a very talented man. However, when compared to your exceptional skills...”

“What?”

“I dare say... he cannot help you with your swordsmanship training at his skill level...”

“You are worried about the fact that this sword level is not at the level to help me, yes?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” the duke said, lowering his head further. The others lightly nodded as if they shared his sentiment. There was no doubt that she was training; that much was clear. But that Lloyd Frontera was assisting her in her training? They thought he was too weak to help her.

She chuckled as she scanned everyone and grinned contentedly. “Oh, I guess the news has not reached you yet. I tell you now. Lloyd Frontera has become a swordmaster.” She smiled as if the accomplishment were hers.

There was another ripple of shock in the room. Everyone fell into silence.

Lloyd Frontera has become a swordmaster?

Their stupefied gazes traveled to Lloyd.

How?

The whole situation defied basic reason. Swordmasters were extremely uncommon, and throughout history, aristocrats and knight families made every effort to raise their offsprings to be swordmasters. However, their success rate was pitifully low and their efforts never proportionately translated to that level of mastery.

A whole family could prosper with wealth and fame just by nurturing one swordmaster... That is how powerful and rare of an existence they are.

Swordmasters were so important that the mere presence of one deterred invasions from other nations, and the presence of several even outshined the strength of a regional military.

Lloyd Frontera has become a swordmaster?

It was shocking news as no one had ever heard a rumor or hearsay about Lloyd’s swordsmanship before. They could not believe it, even though the announcement had come from the queen.

“Lloyd Frontera,” called Queen Magentano as if she read their minds. “Prove yourself.”

“Your words are my command.” Lloyd then awkwardly took the sword that she handed to him.

Just then.

Fwoooosh! A brilliant ray of light appeared and wrapped around the sword like a torch on fire, and Queen Magentano spoke to put the matter to rest once and for all. “This has to be proof of Lloyd Frontera’s mastery in sword fighting and the veracity of my words. Does anyone still wish to voice out their opposition?”

Of course, there was no one. Since Lloyd Frontera was now confirmed to be a sword master, it would be the same as insulting the queen’s authority if they tried to dispute and argue against her. Everyone lowered their heads in quiet, and the corners of her lips showed on her face.

“I am delighted to be acknowledged by all of you. I deeply appreciate that you are on board with me.”

Her words felt like a gavel hitting the board to give a verdict to a matter in their ears, and this declaration was non-negotiable. Just like that, along with the announcement of yet another sword master in the Magentano Kingdom, the contentious and ebullient training between Queen Magentano and Lloyd began.

♣

“Your Majesty,” said Lloyd, “Take a deep breath.”

“Like this?” *Hmph!*

“Excellent, Your Majesty,” commented Lloyd humbly as he concentrated.

Ziiing! His right hand thrust the amplified mana from the manaheart into her left hand as one mana circle spun.

Great. I see it.

This allowed Lloyd to see and feel the mana circulation flow in her left arm.

It’s worse than I thought.

Lloyd swallowed dryly. Her left arm was in a more serious condition than he expected upon examination.

The mana isn’t circulating from below her shoulder.

While the rest of the circulatory system, including lymph flow and blood flow, was within normal limits, the mana’s circulation path was either obstructed or clogged, and Lloyd had no idea what was causing this, but he could foretell the consequences.

Once the mana supply is cut, the arm will start to die. That will lead it to paralyze and decay.

With a sense of relief that he was familiar with the Asrahan Core Technique, he infused her arm with additional mana and set about clearing the obstructions.

“Ouch.” She pulled her arm a little as if the process stung.

Lloyd’s gaze turned worrisome. “Please do not move, Your Majesty.”

“How about talking like this?” she asked.

“That is fine, Your Majesty.”

“Why is that?”

“Because the key here is that you do not move your left arm.”

“So, smacking your head with my right arm is not a problem?”

“That seems to be a grave problem, Your Majesty.”

“Why is that? Did you not say that I can move any part of my body other than my left arm?”

“That will hurt my feelings, Your Majesty.”

“...”

“Hahaha...” Lloyd laughed awkwardly.

“...”

“Please do not kill me.”

“It is enough that you are self-aware of your wrongdoing. Tell me, is this supposed to hurt?” asked Queen Magentano.

“Does it hurt a lot?” asked Lloyd worriedly.

“Hmph, I would say it stings rather than hurts. It feels like a hot nail is being drilled into my bones.”

“That sounds easily worse than a sting,” observed Lloyd.

“My patience and strength do not permit me to fuss over such a sensation like this.”

“Hmm... How about this, Your Majesty?” Lloyd then gave her some more mana.

“Ack!” she screamed in agony, but her humiliation was clear: her cheeks turned scarlet and her eyes gleamed with a threatening menace. “You must want to die.”

“Please forgive me, Your Majesty,” Lloyd said politely, but he was hesitant to back down so quickly since this was his only opportunity to annoy the queen of a kingdom lawfully.

“Ouch!” She winced again.

‘“This is all a part of treatment, so please forgive this lowly servant with your endless generosity and virtue. I shall then be overwhelmed with gratitude and obey you even more than before.”

“Ouch!!”

Lloyd pumped more mana into her arm with a wide grin. Each time he did, her frown deepened. However, his triumph was fleeting and limited to the daytime he spent treating her. The tables turned at night, and the queen emerged victorious.

“Sign them.”

“...”

The night was long. They untied their hands for a moment to bathe and change into pajamas. From that moment, a hellish mountain of paperwork was waiting to be signed by Lloyd. With his right hand tied to the queen, he was forced to awkwardly write with his trembling, left hand.

“By the way, Your Majesty?” called Lloyd.

“Yes?”

“Come to think of it, there is something strange,” expressed Lloyd.

“What is it that you find it strange?”

“Why do you take pleasure in teasing me?” asked Lloyd politely.

“You are curious about that?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Hmm. That is a very simple question.”

“Could you please enlighten me?” asked Lloyd.

“That is no problem. I find you truly annoying.”

“Your Majesty?” Lloyd looked at her, clearly surprised to hear her.

“Even right now. I feel spiteful seeing those round eyes of yours. I am nearly overcome with the desire to hit the back of your chestnut-shaped head.”

Shocked, Lloyd looked away.

“And when you look away in surprise just like now, I wish to challenge you to a duel.”

“...”

“Now that I am seeing you focus on the paperwork, clearly regretting your choice to ask, I suddenly want to harass you until morning and deprive you of sleep.”

“...”

“Are you bored of signing papers? I can see that your hand is not moving fast.”

“...!”

Scribble! The night turned to morning as Lloyd’s fingers worked at the speed of light. But when the sun went down again, he was compelled to sign the bundle of documents once more. In an instant, two months went by, and finally, they started to see the results of their training.

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Chapter 371: Bearing Fruit (1)

“Holy.”

“Speak,” said the queen.

“Moly.”

“I just asked about my condition.”

“Guacamole.”

“...”

“Oh, forgive me, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd, quickly brushing off the confusion from his face.

It was the end of the second month of training, and the queen’s sharp stare at Lloyd caused him to lift his head and respond.

“Your conditions have improved beyond my expectations.”

“They have?” Replied Queen Magentano.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

The queen nodded. It was true. Lloyd had performed a thorough inspection on the flow of mana within her body as month two finished, and the result was stunning.

“Your accomplishments are far greater than I had anticipated, Your Majesty.”

“Are they?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. Most of the key routes through which Asrahan Core Technique could operate have been established already.”

“Go on,” said the queen.

“There is no need to take the trivial steps that I have had in my mind, anymore.”

“Really?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

This was true as well. When Lloyd had first suggested the two-month training, he was hoping to at least mitigate the paralysis on the queen’s left arm.

Because that was the most I could expect given the situation. She was already an accomplished swordmaster, and learning a new core technique was virtually impossible.

However, it seemed Lloyd’s expectations were completely off.

Major routes through which the Asrahan Core Technique could operate have settled nicely. While the smaller ones still require training, this is astounding. Glimpse of hope? My butt. It’s an entire flood of it!

Lloyd had estimated the queen’s success rate of learning this technique to be less than 10 percent before the training. With the recent accomplishment, however, it was now more like 50 percent.

“Have discomforts on your left arm drastically decreased as of late whenever I injected mana into it?” asked Lloyd, examining the queen’s arm more meticulously.

“They have. I barely feel them anymore.”

“I am inclined to think the physical resistance within your body has subsided, as the routes settled.”

“Hmm. It must be thanks to my natural knack.”

“I am inclined to think it’s thanks to my wonderful talent.”

“Most definitely because of my extraordinary endurance and affinity.”

“My selfless, diligent efforts must be finally paying off.”

“I am astounded by my superior ability to master one thing after another.”

“I am compelled to give a big round of applause to my sacrificial endeavor.”

“So you’re going to keep talking back.”

“Your grace knows no bounds... Please forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“Tsk. You and your requests for forgiveness in situations like these.”

“Forgive me, but there still is a huge obstacle to overcome, Your Majesty.”

“By a huge obstacle,” said the queen, frowning one eyebrow. “Do you mean the formation of the mana circle you had mentioned a few days ago?”

“Precisely, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd proceeded to explain.

“You have successfully established the framework required for the operation of the Asrahan Core Technique, Your Majesty. However, you still lack the core component in the mana circle.”

“Mana circle...”

“Yes, Your Majesty. That is absolutely necessary for you to operate the technique on your own.”

“Which makes sense. I am still in need of your help because I do not have that,” Queen Magentano nodded.

The lack of the mana circle in her body called for Lloyd’s assistance in operating the Asrahan Core Technique. As soon as the rope binding the

hands of the queen and Lloyd was untied, her left arm would feel the discomfort associated with paralysis due to the dissipation of mana.

“So, the formation of the mana circle to consistently provide mana to my left arm through the Asrahan Core Technique on my own would finally seal this dreadful training. Correct?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. Your wisdom knows no bounds.”

“So it is correct?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Hmm.”

“...”

“Hmm.”

“May I ask why you’re staring at me like that, Your Majesty...?”

“So you found the two months you spent with me dreadful.”

“That isn’t...”

“You just said yes to my question. Did you not?”

“...”

“That this dreadful training could finally come to an end?”

“...”

“What a terrible queen I am, for having failed to realize how dreadful and boring it is to stay in training for two whole months.”

“...”

“Isn’t that right?”

Please don’t kill me.

Lloyd trembled like a leaf against the wind, shortly before he overworked his cerebral cortex to come up with a response.

“Ahem. Anyhow, it is true that you must overcome the obstacle of forming a mana circle, to continue curing your left arm through the Asrahan Core Technique.”

“Okay, and?”

“And thanks to the two months of wonderful and joyous training with you, Your Majesty, the results are much better than expected. Since the structure of the mana flow to enable the technique has been nearly established, we should be able to skip the tedious steps and jump right into the last phase.”

“Ha. Is that so?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. I will help with the formation of your mana circle with a quick charge.”

“Okay... a quick charge?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. Do you recall when I absorbed a great amount of your mana in the past?”

“...”

“I will perform something like that again.”

“Tsk.”

“Your Majesty?”

“Go on,” said the queen, after frowning subtly.

She did remember the incident during which she had lost a tremendous amount of mana to Lloyd, as her life was threatened.

Although it shouldn't be as annoying since I haven't been poisoned or anything.

But she certainly did not enjoy the experience. Lloyd continued to elaborate as she reminisced.

"Truth be told, your biggest problem lies in that you are too advanced as a warrior."

"Too advanced?"

"Yes, Your Majesty. To draw an analogy, you're like a completed piece of art."

"And?"

"What would happen, then, if I were to absorb a fair amount of your mana?"

"Hmm. That would create an emptiness of mana here and there, albeit partially."

"That's correct, Your Majesty. The painting on the completed artwork would be removed partially, revealing what's underneath temporarily."

"That is accurate, Your Majesty."

Lloyd put a genuine smile on his face, impressed by the queen's wit yet again.

I tell her about one piece of the puzzle, and she grasps the entire picture.

Lloyd thought she didn't become a swordmaster for nothing and continued.

"I believe now is the best time to summon Sir Javier Asrahan here."

"Sir Javier Asrahan?"

“Yes, Your Majesty. He will stay by our side and make sure we are both safe.”

“Okay. Call him immediately.”

With verbal approval from the queen, Javier, who had been waiting in the room of honored guests, was summoned straight away. The knight’s eyes were a bit red for some reason, however.

“Why are your eyes like that?” Lloyd asked.”

“...”

Javier did not reply. Instead, he gave Lloyd a rather cold stare through those red eyes. Lloyd squinted at the sight and added.

“Come on, it’s been a while since we last met. Don’t be like that.”

“...”

“Please don’t tell me you’re too overjoyed to see me.”

“...”

“Or you’re trying your hardest to hold your tears in.”

“...”

“Tsk. Your feelings were hurt.”

“No.”

“Got you. You responded to that right away.”

“Not at all.”

“Ha. You are clearly upset because I made you stay in the honored guest room for two whole months.”

“...”

“And your insomnia kicked back in because I wasn’t there to sing lullabies each night.”

“My eyes are red because I read until late last night.”

“I didn’t say anything about your eyes though.”

“...”

“You’re so bad at lying sometimes. Let’s get to work anyway. You know why you’re here, right?”

“Yeah. You explained before.”

“Good. You must take a good look at me and Her Majesty.”

“Understood,” Javier nodded, reassuring Lloyd.

Thank goodness I have him with us. I don’t remember anything whenever I use Quick Charge.

He would completely lose himself and fail to realize what would transpire around him, and this could potentially put the queen in danger.

That’s why I need to watch over us.

Javier was the only one who was capable of such a task because he knew the Asrahan Core Technique. Even within the range of the quick charge, the knight was able to disturb the flow of mana, mitigate the animosity, and avoid losing his own. He could also examine and monitor the amount and property of the mana exchanged between Lloyd and the queen, as well as the trend of mana being created and recovered within Her Majesty’s body. This meant that in the event the queen would be in danger, he could inject his mana onto her and secure her safety. Because Javier could perform all of these, he was a security guard required for this specific quick charge session.

“Let’s go.”

They headed down to the royal training arena for the queen, who strictly commanded others not to approach them. After the three of them stopped in the center, Lloyd untied the rope binding them together and sat on the ground facing her.

“Are you ready, Your Majesty?”

“Yeah,” said the queen, nodding with determination in her eyes.

“The partial voids of mana will occur during the process of absorption. Please remember to perform the Asrahan Core Technique onto those voids.”

“I will.”

They made eye contact and understood the preparations were complete. Without further ado, Lloyd opened the status window and activated this ability.

Ding.

[Asrahan Core Technique Option 5: Quick Charge is activated.]

[A large amount of mana will be absorbed from a random target near you.]

That’s when the strange transformation began. Lloyd’s three-way circle began to move like the predator stepping out of its lair, sniffing around to look for suitable prey to satiate the hunger. After finding the victim, the circle opened its vicious mouth and bit without hesitation.

Zing! The mana circle began to absorb mana from all targets in the vicinity in an instant, including Queen Magentano.

Mm...!

The queen inadvertently took an empty breath as soon as the quick charge began. She couldn’t breathe properly. Her vision blurred and she felt pain

all over her body, as though she had just fallen from a tree, shortly before sensing an exodus of mana.

Mm... Hmph!

It’s been a while since she last felt this. The queen bit her lips amid the massive headache and opened her eyes widely to remain conscious and focused. She desperately recalled Lloyd’s instructions and performed them.

Partial voids of mana... that will occur during the process... of losing a large amount of mana...

It felt as if she was losing a large sum of blood in an instant, before becoming an empty shell to be shattered in the end. She examined her inner self in agony and deliberately stopped the flow of mana that had constantly been active ever since she became a swordmaster. She then endeavored to identify the void of mana that was supposed to be present. She began to feel it slowly but surely.

There.

It was temporary. In less than one second, a tiny space the size of a pea was spotted. Queen Magentano reacted immediately.

I must hurry.

She rushed her mana and established the foundation of the Asrahan Core Technique, shortly before the void was filled. As soon as the technique did what it was supposed to, another void appeared in a different spot. The queen did not lose track of it and extended the technique onto the new void. One spot in one second became two spots, and then five spots. As the absorption process continued, the speed at which these spots appeared grew at an exponential rate as if a fierce thunderstorm rattled the roof with raindrops. It was a session of immense tension and ferocity. She kept fighting to spot the voids, performed the Core Technique, endured the pain, and held herself together. She hung on and finally succeeded.

“...Urgh!”

Cough! Queen Magentano coughed out a handful of blood, but it did not hurt at all. Rather, it felt great as though fish bones that had been stuck in her throat for a long time were just removed. She felt this great freshness in her heart the moment coughed the blood out, and that was when a two-way seed had formed around her mana heart.

Zing. The seed began to circulate slowly but surely. It rotated, compressed itself, grew bigger, and became denser. It then formed a small, yet gigantic, circular ring, unleashing the light to commemorate its birth.

Zing! A two-way mana circle was formed around the queen's heart just like that. Queen Alicia Termina Magentano, the extremely powerful swordmaster, had finally achieved a double-circle status.

Around the same time, a courier from Namaran was rushing towards the royal capital of Magenta, carrying an urgent message.

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Chapter 372: Bearing Fruit (2)

Zing!

The flow of mana circulated through the two-way circle and expanded its output, letting out a fierce rattling noise. Queen Magentano opened her eyes at the feeling of the mana flood pounding her body.

She could feel that the clotted mana flow had reopened. It had been reconstructed and reconnected. Mana traveled throughout the body without restraint, passing through the shoulders, palms, and fingers, before returning to the heart, forming a circle.

Zing!

It continued to rotate and regenerate. It spun, expanded, and overflowed. It was literally pounding the queen's body in between her breaths. It was a whole new degree of prowess that she embraced for the first time since she became a swordmaster.

What the...

Queen Magentano was flabbergasted by what was transpiring within her. Everything about her mana flow was changing; the complex, maze-like old routes were being combined and fused to form wider and simpler pathways to connect vital parts of the body.

So this is what the Asrahan Core Technique does.

It was even more astounding to feel it firsthand. She was in awe of the core technique that had produced a grandmaster and a swordmaster. It stirred up ambition within her heart.

If I could raise an army of knights capable of using this technique...

Queen Magentano was positive that her kingdom wouldn't only become the most dominant domain in the entire continent, but conquer the lands and put

her banners throughout the world. While it was a fascinating idea, she quickly refuted it and shook her head.

No.

The queen convinced herself that it was a stupid dream, for two reasons. First was the trust she had shared thus far with Lloyd Frontera.

This man went through all this trouble just to cure my paralysis. I can't take advantage of this act of good faith by sharing this technique with others.

She knew she was going to lose more: Lloyd and Javier's loyalty.

Secondly, it won't be beneficial in the long run.

Should she pass down the teachings of the Asrahan Core Technique to knights and soldiers under her command, there was not a shred of a doubt that the Magentano Dynasty would be so dominant in the years to come. However, it wasn't going to last long.

The secrets of this technique will be leaked to other kingdoms, and every individual who could wield a sword would emulate this technique across the entire continent sooner or later.

The relative advantage of having this technique would fade. It was best not to share this with anyone else. It was better to appreciate Lloyd and Javier's trust to pass down this technique to her and embrace it by herself.

"...Phew."

Queen Magentano let out a deep breath after coming to the conclusion. Each time she did, waste energy from her old flow was excreted, purifying the mana flowing through the circle in the process. The paralysis on her left arm, which had caused so much discomfort, quickly faded away.

It's fully healed.

The queen clenched and released her left fist multiple times and lifted her head to glance at Lloyd with confidence. The man was continuing to

perform the quick charge.

Whoosh!

She saw an immense amount of mana being absorbed by Lloyd. The sand on the training ground was drying up and leaves flying by crumbled into dust. Yet, Queen Magentano wasn't in any agony despite being physically within the range of quick charge. She wasn't losing mana at all.

So this is what happens if I embrace mana leaving my body, instead of resisting it.

The queen grasped the concept of the circle. She stared at Lloyd again and put a smile on her face, enjoying and appreciating all he was doing for her until the quick charge finally ended.

Ding.

[Asrahan Core Technique Option 5: Quick Charge duration has expired.]

Zing...

The fierce session of mana absorption came to an end, and the mana circle wasn't going wild anymore. Lloyd slowly opened his eyes and looked into the space, searching for the new pop-up message.

[You have fully cured the terminal illness of Queen Magentano through selfless care and efforts over two months.]

[Queen Magentano's left arm was destined to disappear for good due to the predestined flow of fate governed by cause and effect. However, you successfully reinstated mana to her left arm through adequate response, marvelous endeavor, and selfless service.]

[Queen Alicia Termina Magentano was deeply moved by your heroics and began praising you in her own way.]

[You have unlocked a new title.]

Huh?

Having failed to anticipate this, Lloyd quickly rolled his eyes.

[New title <Savior of Magentano> has been unlocked.]

[Savior of Magentano]

[Title Level: Personal Praise]

[You have always looked for me only when you were in need, and I thought it was going to be the same this time around. However, I am overjoyed to admit that I was wrong. You stayed by my side day and night never crossed the line, and provided selfless services, finally delivering me. You cheap, annoying, and absurd Frontera boy continue to be in my thoughts for some reason. I know not what I am supposed to do about your acts of good faith. Your kind heart. I know not how I can repay you.]

[Compliment Effect: As the lifesaver of Queen Magentano, you have her absolute trust. Your opinion and advice will be fully backed and supported by the queen without condition, and those that antagonize you or attempt to harm you will be declared enemies of the kingdom regardless of status and identity.]

[Title Region: Wherever Alicia Termina Magentano is]

[Active Period of Title: As long as Queen Magentano is alive]

...*Holy.*

Lloyd inadvertently blinked his eyes multiple times to check the message. Two things were clear.

Her left arm was completely cured. She successfully learned the Asrahan Core Technique.

It was as the message stated; the queen’s terminal illness had been cured. There also was another thing Lloyd instinctively realized.

“Why are you staring into blank space like that?”

“...”

“Are you alright?”

“Your Majesty.”

Lloyd quickly took a step back and spoke in a courtly manner.

“Allow me to congratulate you on successful mastery of the Asrahan Core Technique and your left arm’s full recovery.”

“Congratulate? I almost died because of you.”

“...”

“I jest. I do not deserve to be congratulated. Rather, I feel indebted to you.”

“Your grace knows no bounds.”

“Really?”

“...”

“I know the exact line you say every time you have nothing else to say. It’s about time you stop using the same line, but I suppose you’re going to ask for forgiveness following my response anyway.”

“...”

“Am I wrong?”

“Uhm, well...”

Lloyd put an awkward smile on his face instead, for an obvious reason.

Whoa. Why is she looking at me so gracefully like that?

The look Queen Magentano gave Lloyd was sweeter than before. It used to be that of composure and charisma, but now it was full of trust and friendliness, like pizza full of cheese.

The new compliment effect is... absolutely amazing.

Winning endless trust and faith from the queen, as well as absolute support and grace, could already be felt with the gaze.

I don't know if I feel comfortable about it, but I suppose it doesn't hurt.

Lloyd concluded that it wouldn't hurt to have this kind of support from the queen and shrugged his shoulders.

What am I thinking? It's an absolute win. The ruler of the kingdom that is on its way to dominance across the continent backing me up like that? I can pick out a certain individual as an enemy, and she would send her most trusted knights to apprehend that person immediately.

That wasn't going to be the only benefit.

I can even ask for more financial support.

This was what Lloyd was truly after. He didn't care much about absolute faith or sending knights to help him out. In fact, the best benefactor was someone who could financially support him all the way.

Anyone who has more money and could spare some for me is my king and queen. I love you, my queen.

Lloyd organized his thoughts quickly and bowed respectfully, showing the top of his head in the process.

"I don't know what to say about your unending grace as a humble servant. But to tell you the truth, I only made proper preparations and laid the foundation. It is you, Your Majesty, that took advantage of this opportunity and successfully mastered it."

"Hmm. So you even mean to make it my achievement."

“I am nothing but a faithful subject, so whatever I accomplish is your accomplishment, Your Majesty.”

“Ha. You’ve always been good with your lips.”

“All thanks to you, Your Majesty.”

“Do you honey your tongue up before you’re granted an audience with me, each time?”

“Huh? N-no, Your Majesty.”

“Then?”

“I naturally feel compelled to speak in this manner each time I am granted an audience with you, Your Majesty.”

“Ha.”

Queen Magentano inadvertently chuckled, while Lloyd continued to think.

Whew. It worked out in the end. Her left arm was cured. And now...

Lloyd wondered when the enforced fate phenomenon was going to take place again, and which event was going to trigger it. While he still had no idea, there was a way to find out.

Should I look at the ending spoiler later in the evening? Or I can go back to the Frontera estate and use the Jewel of Truth.

Both were decent methods. What was important for Lloyd at the moment was to prevent the incidents that could trigger the restoration of that tragic destiny each time in the future.

I wonder just how many times I could manage to do this.

Lloyd had to find a more comprehensive way to solve this problem once and for all in the meantime. He strengthened his resolve by continuing to

remind him of what he knew until he saw a white banner flying in one corner of the training arena.

Huh?

Lloyd was reminded of that particular banner. He had traveled to and from the royal palace, and into the training arena multiple times to know the significance of it.

Wait. That's the banner to notify an emergency.

The white banner was supposed to be raised when the queen was training rigorously and thus difficult to approach. It was to alert the queen that there was an urgent message to be brought to her attention.

"What is it?"

The queen had seen the banner as well and waved. A royal guard rushed to her presence immediately.

"Your Majesty. I bring an urgent message by the courier from Namaran."

"Urgent message?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"Where is this courier?"

"He is waiting for the audience with you in the audience chamber, Your Majesty."

"I see. Hmm. Actually, I think it'd be better to hear this urgent news in my study instead of the audience chamber, which is usually full of eyes and ears. Bring the courier into my study."

"As you command, Your Majesty."

After the royal guard was dismissed, the queen looked at Lloyd again.

“Lloyd Frontera.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Her eyes were devoid of mischief suddenly, as she made a proposition.

“Will you come with me?”

“It is a great honor to be given a chance to accompany you, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd thought this was actually not a bad idea to see the courier from Namaran bringing urgent news, out of all places.

Something must have happened in Namaran for the courier to have brought an urgent message. What could it be?

Lloyd wondered what could have transpired, and why it had to be now. The timing felt suspicious, as though someone was handing over another problem to solve after another. It was like the next duty to take care of shortly after the previous one, and a new case after closing one.

A huge event took place in Namaran in the original novel, the Knight of Blood and Iron, too.

He recalled Namaran’s Wall in the original story. The entire city of Namaran was surrounded by a magical barrier by the dark mages, until Javier managed, albeit barely, to take care of this. The royal lady of Namaran had perished during this incident.

But I prevented it. I saved the lady and constructed four-way protective structures for the city. All dark mages should have been eliminated back then because the queen personally led the knights to do so.

But something felt amiss for some reason as if something unanticipated was about to happen.

Should the enforced fate phenomenon kick off, something would surely happen in Namaran since it was the scene of a terrible event in the original story.

In other words, there was a high chance that Namaran could be the place to trigger the tragic restoration of destiny.

I must be on my guard. I'd better get as much information from the courier as possible.

Lloyd strengthened his resolve constantly as he walked beside the queen into her study. The courier from Namaran who had been waiting quickly paid respect to the queen and handed over the scroll containing the urgent message.

"Hmm."

Lloyd noticed that Queen Magentano's eyes sparkled as she read the scroll, and wondered what message was written there. She tilted her head in an unsure manner and glanced at Lloyd, making his curiosity even greater.

"Lloyd Frontera."

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"It looks like your presence is required in Namaran, immediately."

"Huh?"

The queen gave the scroll to Lloyd, who took it and read it right away. The content was rather disturbing.

Are you freaking kidding me?!

Lloyd gritted his teeth inadvertently.

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Chapter 373: Crushing Obstacles (1)

“Bibeong!”

A refreshing roar welcomed a new day along with the sunrise over the eastern mountain range on the Frontera Estate. The sunlight shone brightly upon the count’s mansion, gracing the interior through the windows of the guest chambers. There was one particular room, however, where the sunlight failed to penetrate through the windows, due to the blackout curtains that were hung over with the intent to completely shut off any source of light. Behind the curtains was Dragon King Verkis, attempting to cast communication magic throughout the morning.

“Come on...! Answer!”

Beep. Beep. Beep.

“Ugh...”

Beep. Beep. Beep.

“Come on...”

Beep. Beep. Beep.

“Tsk. Failed again.”

Verkis was disappointed to embrace the situation. He could tell that there was nothing wrong with the casting formula from the flow of mana; the communication spell was working properly. However, the actual connection was not being established again. There was only one explanation.

She’s deliberately ignoring my calls again.

It appeared that his wife was more upset than he had anticipated, causing him to lose patience and feel insecure.

This isn’t good. What do I do? Should I go back and ask for forgiveness?

It has been some time since he left the Sea Dragon Cave and came to the Frontera Estate, which meant that his wife's journey was about to be over soon.

Please don't tell me she's going to ignore my calls until she gets back. That's not good, because that means she'll be upset when she arrives. What am I supposed to do? I don't want to be on the receiving end of her wrath firsthand. It doesn't feel great to be given anything but hard pieces of bread for each meal.

The more he thought about it, the bigger the problem seemed. It would be a disaster to see his wife, whom he hadn't seen for a while, come back with a callous sneer on her face. That was why Verkis attempted to establish a connection for one last time, unlike any other morning.

"Please... pick up!"

Beep. Beep. Beep.

"I am so sorry! So just answer!"

Beep. Beep. Beep.

"I'm getting up early every morning to try these calls to make up for it. You know how much of a good job I've been doing, right? So please just answer!"

Beep. Beep. Click.

"Yes, my love?"

"If you just answer the call this one, I'll do the dishes for the rest of..."

"Rest of our lives?"

"...Huh?"

"My husband?"

“...”

Verkis remained silent momentarily until he quickly grasped the situation. The connection had finally been established.

“A-are you alright?”

“I am as good as ever, my love.”

“Please don’t tell me you got hurt, starved, got bitten by a mosquito, ran your pinky toe across the frame of the door, threw a tantrum because you ate something wrong, bled while trying to remove acne, cried because you missed me, or anything.”

“Not at all, my love. There is no need for you to worry about me.”

“Really? That’s good to know.”

Phew.

Verkis breathed a sigh of relief. But a question that figuratively smashed a heavily dense morning star right on his chest followed immediately.

“But my love? Did you just say you were going to do the dishes for the rest of our lives?”

“Huh? No. You heard it wrong.”

“Huh?”

“I was only telling you to hustle.”

“Hmm...”

“I’m serious.”

“Hmm...”

“For real.”

“But I heard your statement in a loud and clear voice with my own two ears.”

Verkis refused to respond, as his clever wife continued to bombard his ears with a scary tone.

“Although I haven’t had a proper education, I still remember the saying by wise men from the past to this day. Have you ever heard of the phrase *a man of his words* by any chance?”

“Well... I guess?”

“Excellent, as expected of you. A man of his words never goes back on what he speaks, because he values his words more than gold. A real man must not, as such, take back what he lets out from his lips.”

“I do know what it means.”

“Do you remember?”

“Of course I do. You used the same logic and made some poor bastard carry around a flower on his head for the rest of his life.”

“Yes. That was Sir Michael.”

“Yeah. The founder of the Magentano Dynasty. I do remember.”

“Of course you do. I had faith in you.”

“Faith? What do you mean?”

“I can’t wait to reunite with you and see you take care of the dishes for the rest of our lives, as soon as I return.”

Verkis felt as though he was just sentenced to death, but it was too late to turn it around. Instead, he shook off the teardrops that naturally formed around his eyes and asked again.

“When are you going to return, then?”

“Well, I answered your call because I wanted to speak to you about this.”

“Did something happen?”

“No...”

“Then?”

“My mother is absolutely in love with the journey.”

“Huh?”

“Not just my mother. Lady Flores and Iris are also enjoying it so much.”

“Wait. So the old hag, Flores, and our daughter are all having so much fun.”

“That is correct. I was going to ask if it would be alright for us to travel for another year before returning.”

“Hmm.”

“My love?”

“...Tsk. I do miss you tons, but I suppose I have no choice.”

“Do you really mean it?”

“I have no choice. I can’t decline if all of you are enjoying it so much. But under one condition,” said Verkis, in a more solemn voice than ever. “I’ll let you travel for another year if you forget about doing dishes.”

“But a man of his words...”

“...”

“...Never goes back on what he says.”

“H-how about skipping wake-up calls for the next year then?”

“...”

“This too?”

“Hmm. Okay.”

“Really?”

“Really.”

“For real?”

“For real.”

The permission to sleep in each morning was finally given by his queen, his wife, his everything.

“I actually saw you struggle but manage to get up each morning to make such calls. Although you did sleep in a few days, the efforts you made to keep the promise really touched my heart.”

“...Uhm. Okay.”

“Yeah. So I decided not to say anything even if you sleep in each morning for the next year.”

“R-really?”

“Yeah. Besides, you allowed me to travel for another year too anyway.”

“...O-okay! Thank you! I love you!”

“Me too. Please don’t let me stop you from resting.”

The communication magic ended with that. Verkis immediately threw his body on the bed as the effect of the spell subsided. He had acted as though he was against the idea of his wife being away for another year, but it was quite the contrary in reality.

“Ahahaha! Gahahahaha!”

Verkis rolled on the bed like a child having so much fun, out of pure joy. It was as though any husband whose wife and kids were away on a trip just got a call from the wife saying they’ll be spending another week before returning. Verkis put on a genuine smile on his face and began to think about what he was going to do for the next year, like the husband contemplating whether to order pizza or Chinese food as soon as hanging up on the call.

Alright!

Verkis organized his pillows and bed sheets, before putting on the comfy blanket to start dreaming. But his joyful anticipation didn’t last long.

Knock-knock!

The knocking noise was clearer than ever, followed by an untimely clear voice reporting in.

“Your Majesty. It’s Raphael of Thrones, reporting for duty. Have you awakened?”

“...”

“I just came back from jogging alongside the citizens of the estate this morning, and I had to stop by to report because it felt so refreshing. May I invite you?”

“...”

“Or we can play this game called chess. I learned how to play from the count last evening. The games humans invented are quite fun.”

“...”

“Or we can work on the field alongside farmers. The act of caring for the crop, harvesting it, and putting it on the table to share with neighbors actually seems like an enjoyable thing to do.”

“...”

“Your Majesty?”

Knock-knock!

“...”

Verkis contemplated whether or not to grind the Angel of Thrones or Thorns down into molecules or make him dissipate into thin air with the help of the archangel. He was overtaken by the feeling of annoyance that was as strong as a cup of espresso with extra shots. As a matter of fact, this wasn’t the first time he did this.

He’s way too active and friendly with people, damn it.

Raphael had adapted to the life in this estate a little too well for Verkis’s taste. Just like his title suggested, he possessed an angelic character and always showed kindness to others. He was full of curiosity, yet had gentle nature; it was natural for him to make friends here and there instead of enemies. He was a born extrovert.

Ugh, it’s not like I can kill him either!

While there was not a shred of a doubt Verkis could get rid of Raphael—effortlessly, too—that was going to create a huge tension between him and the archangel. Verkis did not want that.

Because he’s as good as me.

He recalled an incident during which the confrontation with the archangel led to a physical altercation. They had relocated to a better spot to engage in an all-out battle, causing the routes of two neutron stars and combining them to create a black hole, which ultimately led to the supernova that unleashed extreme gravitational waves.

He took that hit head-on and stood still like nothing happened.

Verkis had never seen anyone that could withstand something like that, aside from himself. He was genuinely astounded by the archangel and wondered if the king of hell was also like this.

I don't want trouble with guys like them. It's annoying.

But the knocking sound and the waking voice of the angel rattled his ears constantly. Verkis tried his best to ignore it. He plugged his ears and turned around, thinking what he had to do. He couldn't bear it anymore. He couldn't sleep anymore. Verkis determined it would be better to go to a solitary place, erect magical barriers, and go to sleep for one whole year. While getting up from the bed at the moment felt like a lot of work, it was going to be better than this. The dragon king barely managed to get up from the bed.

I'd better get going.

***

"I should head to Namaran straight away," said Lloyd, as he folded the scroll containing the urgent message.

"It looks like your presence is required, doesn't it?" Queen Magentano replied, making eye contact with her subject.

"Yes, Your Majesty," Lloyd replied with a bitter smile on his face. "If this message is true, that is."

Lloyd's smile became even bitterer as he recalled what was written in the scroll, which did not contain much.

The slope in Namaran is slowly crumbling down...? This indicates that the construction project I led there before is somehow being compromised due to the mysterious mana explosions.

That was what the scroll brought by the courier contained. Lloyd frowned inadvertently.

This doesn't feel good. It hasn't even been long after I led the project there. Even if they were to slack on maintenance, it wouldn't start crumbling down already.

The city of Namaran, which was situated on top of the cliff, faced great danger as the slope on one side had shown signs of crumbling down. Lloyd had led a project to install huge piles and anchors on the entire slope to stabilize that. The idea that it was beginning to fall apart already was unacceptable. It was realistically impossible.

I don't do half-assed jobs when I work on a construction project. And the latter part of the message is what worries me more. Mysterious mana explosions?

He wondered if these were new phenomena that hinted at the enforced fate phenomenon, or what could trigger it. In fact, he strongly suspected it.

There is a chance.

Now that he thought about it, Namaran was a place in which a huge incident called *Namaran's Wall* had taken place in the original novel. Lloyd had prevented it, thwarted the evil plans of the dark mages, and slain the hell knight that was being summoned. He even successfully saved the young lady of the estate, who was destined to die during the incident but survived and succeeded the Count of Namaran.

In that aspect, Namaran is perhaps one of the places that greatly altered the flow of the original story. There is a chance that a new form of restoration of destiny could be triggered there.

Lloyd came to the conclusion quickly and bowed to the queen.

"Please allow me to take my leave, Your Majesty."

"Are you leaving already?"

"It looks like it's imminent, Your Majesty."

"Understood. Hurry."

To Lloyd’s relief, the queen did not hold him back. Instead, it appeared that the queen read Lloyd’s facial expression and got a rough idea, although she wouldn’t imagine the details involving the enforced fate phenomenon in her wildest dreams. However, she let out a terrible joke to bid Lloyd a temporary farewell, having noticed his desire to be on the move immediately.

“Don’t die. It’s a command.”

“Of course, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd left the royal palace immediately afterward and hopped on the back of Draggy, who was on standby outside. Draggy stomped on the ground.

“To Namaran!”

Lloyd headed southward and flew in supersonic speed, past mountains, waterways, and vast fields, as well as villages, fortresses, and plains. The city atop the cliff, that he was so familiar with, was finally in sight. Lloyd led Draggy to land below the slopes and walked up on his own feet.

I must examine it with my own two eyes.

Exchanging pleasantries with the Lady of Namaran could wait. Checking if the mysterious phenomenon in this place was related to the predestined event was of more importance. Lloyd quickly climbed the slope and arrived at the scene at which he had installed slope-stabilizing piles and anchors before. He noticed a few compression plates that had been holding anchors down were broken, and a few slope-stabilizing piles were 1/3 of the way removed.

What the hell?!

Lloyd was flabbergasted. Broken compression plates and removed piles, which had been installed deep underground. It was as if a giant of immense strength had come over and thrown a tantrum there. He couldn’t think of any other cause.

But there has to be one since there were mysterious mana explosions as well. I should look into that.

Lloyd retained his composure and continued his examination. He allowed his mana circle to work.

Zing... The circle moved slightly and began to absorb the mana residing in the place little by little. Lloyd embraced the property of the mana absorbed and analyzed it as if he were using a metal detector to detect mines. He went throughout the entire slope to discover the clues leading to the mana explosion. It didn't take him long to find them, thanks to the Asrahan Core Technique.

Why is there mana on the piles...?

Lloyd began to feel mana from the stabilizing piles that were removed one-third of the way from the ground. He examined the property of the mana and realized something right away.

This mana feels familiar.

It wasn't strange at all. He had felt this before, here in this place, when he was getting rid of dark mages. That was the nature of the mana that was emanating from the pile.

Dark Mage. Noctanium. The dark gem. The tool was pre-installed to erect Namaran's Wall in the past. This mana is from that jewel.

A couple of words popped up in Lloyd's head, helping him deduce what was going on.

Somebody is trying to use these things I installed as tools to erect Namaran's Wall... again.

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Chapter 374: Crushing Obstacles (2)

“So, somebody is attempting to erect Namaran’s Wall again, using the structures I had installed as tools.”

Lloyd frowned inadvertently at the realization.

This is definitely the enforced fate phenomenon.

He got the idea, but it was too early to jump to a conclusion. Lloyd decided to continue examining while he was at it.

I should begin with measurements.

[Scanning will now begin.]

Bzzt! The measurement skill was activated, with the underground scanning option toggled on, allowing Lloyd to see the structure of the basement to five meters beneath the ground.

Tsk. The stabilization pipe is broken in the middle.

He noticed the fracture in the fourth meter from the ground. It seemed weird, however.

It’s like a popped piece of gimbap.

It was as if someone put too much meat in the burrito and tried to roll it together anyway, and the tortilla ripped in the middle. The stabilization pile was popped on the outer side, revealing the interior. Lloyd immediately knew why.

Somebody force-extended a huge amount of mana into the pile in a short period. The pile failed to withstand the pressure and broke.

Lloyd processed one potential event at a time and drew a big picture. Someone had force-extended mana into the stabilization pile, pressure rose to cause a fracture on the side, the upper part protruded from the ground due

to the push, the anchors were affected by the impact and the vibration, the plates broke, and the slope crumbled down as a result.

Other areas like this must be the same.

Lloyd suspected this but walked a little bit to confirm his theory, carefully inspecting other stabilization piles and anchors. He was spot on.

I sense the presence of mana only on the broken piles.

The stabilization piles protruding above ground like acne popped halfway above the skin were emanating a rather ominous mana. The fact that it was so subtle made it virtually impossible for anyone who did not practice the Asrahan Core Technique to detect this.

I don't know who did this, but not too shabby.

Lloyd identified the positions of all piles broken due to the extension of mana and connected them like dots on the paper. It drew a certain picture.

A magical seal.

Lloyd was convinced now. Somebody had done this intentionally.

They're trying to re-raise Namaran's Wall. Did a dark mage survive the hunt?

Javier, who had been silently staying next to Lloyd thus far, spoke up as Lloyd seemed to be immersed in thoughts.

"Master Lloyd," said Javier. "Is it as expected?"

"As expected?" Lloyd replied. "What is?"

Lloyd took a glance at Javier, who retained his characteristic composure and chuckled.

"I felt the presence of mana in the broken pile, too."

“It is as you say,” agreed Lloyd. “Do you remember the dark mages from before?”

“Do you think some survived?” Javier asked.

“We’ll find out soon enough.”

“Okay. It’s a relief, though.”

“Relief?” Lloyd wondered. “What do you mean by that?”

“To find out that the slope crumbling down in the urgent message wasn’t because you did a terrible job on the project.”

“Tsk. Do you honestly think I’ll do a poor job on any of my construction projects?”

“Nobody knows what will happen in the future,” Javier shrugged his shoulders, continuing to chuckle. “You’re a snobby person to deal with, and you could have easily designed it to start crumbling down ten years later to demand a large sum of money for maintenance.”

“Stop. My pride won’t let that happen.”

“Really?”

“Really,” Lloyd snorted.

It was true. It was civil engineering that was involved, which would construct public structures that millions of people would end up using. Designing it to break apart naturally over time deliberately was out of the question, even if he despised the company that outsourced the job to him.

“I didn’t spend so much time studying this to do a half-assed job.”

“You studied?”

“I told you before. I learned this knowledge in a dream.”

“I do remember that.”

“Good. I also remember something,” Lloyd added mischievously.

“What do you remember?”

“Lady Ella.”

“...”

Javier’s chuckle immediately subsided. Instead, Lloyd was smiling.

“I had completely forgotten about it because I was too busy with the newest events. But coming back to this place refreshed my nostalgic memories.”

“...”

“Do you remember how hundreds of male laborers lined up each morning to get soup from you?”

“...”

“All of their eyes were sparkling, too. They were like, *ah, Lady Ella of the stunningly cold, yet beautiful stare!*”

“...That’s a memory not worth keeping.”

“So you do remember.”

“No. First time hearing that,” Javier denied. “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“Are you flustered by any chance?”

“...”

“Wait. You just clenched your fist.”

“Sigh.”

Javier let out a huge sigh and chuckled. Lloyd responded with a smile of his own.

“Anyhow. You remember what transpired back then, right? I think somebody is trying to replicate that tragic event.”

“Is this another form of enforced restoration of fate?”

“Yeah. Hmm. I suppose I can call it a new act in a play.”

“Are you saying—“

“Namaran’s Wall will be erected at this rate, if we don’t do anything about it.”

Lloyd was absolutely positive. The broken piles emanating mana were forming a magical seal from a bird’s eye view. He didn’t know who was behind it, but that someone was trying to amplify magic using these, like the dark jewel noctanium he had discovered here in the past.

“What do you intend to do now, Master Lloyd?”

“Hmm,” Lloyd shrugged his shoulders. “What comes to my mind is to remove all broken piles completely and shatter them to dissipate the residing mana. That may deliver a devastating blow to the heinous criminal trying to erect Namaran’s Wall again.”

“Then we should report this to Namaran straight away- -“

“Not yet.”

“Huh?”

Javier’s eyebrows twitched, while Lloyd’s lips lifted.

“Touching the tall grass without warning may scare the snake hiding within.”

Lloyd recalled the old saying about the importance of patience, teaching that rushing things would ruin it in the end. He instinctively knew this was a fitting situation.

“Think about it. If we remove the piles and get rid of the mana, would that wrap things up?”

“Hmm. I don’t think so.”

“Why not?”

“Because the person behind this scheme will certainly come up with another plan.”

“Most likely,” nodded Lloyd, fully agreeing with Javier. “What if that person saw us remove the piles and the mana embedded within? He would definitely realize his plans have been thwarted. Can we remove the piles discreetly? No. We need to enlist the help of Ppodong, Bangul, and the entirety of Skeleton Corps and work on it for a whole day to remove one pile.”

“It looks like it. It will take a lot of time, and there’s no way people wouldn’t know about it.”

“Right. And if he discovers that his plan has been thwarted...”

“If I were him, I would go into hiding and come up with a more discreet plan.”

“Precisely. That would make it more difficult to apprehend him or respond in time.”

Lloyd’s idea was to apprehend the culprit before he had time to flee. Dragging this on instead was only going to make him play the game by the enemy’s rules, potentially making the problem much worse.

“You must have an alternate plan in your mind, then.”

“Of course I do,” Lloyd shrugged his shoulders, before putting on another mischievous smile on his face. “But I’m not going to tell you right now.”

“...”

“Come on. You’re giving me that look again.”

“...”

“Tsk. You’ll find out in due time, so don’t let your feelings get hurt.”

“My feelings weren’t hurt.”

“Really?”

“Yes, because I am a man of a huge heart, unlike Master Lloyd.”

“Hey! What do you mean by that?”

“Are you asking that because you honestly don’t know, or are you asking anyway?”

“Of course I know. I am a man of a heart that is as wide as the sea.”

“Ha.”

“...”

“Okay. I will think of you as a man of a huge heart like me, then.”

“I’m not sure if I’m supposed to be happy about that.”

“You’re not.”

“...”

“Shall we head to the mansion of the Countess of Namaran?”

“Yeah. That’s the next step.”

Lloyd carried a bitter smile on his face as he turned around. Javier followed with a thought in his mind.

Such a liar.

Javier stared through his cold, composed eyes at the back of Lloyd's head. The grandmaster instinctively knew.

But he's a trustworthy person. He's always been this way. He acts like a cheap scoundrel on the outside but puts in a tremendous effort for his father and his house. Although... he's still hiding a lot.

Javier recalled the conversation he just had with Lloyd about the enforced fate, Namaran's Wall that was on its way to be re-erected, and coming up with ways to thwart that evil plan. Those were all believable. However, Javier had doubts about one thing.

You learned about construction and engineering in your dreams? Give me a break.

Javier put a bitter smile on his face inadvertently, having been convinced now. Lloyd's claim that he got knowledge about construction and engineering in his dreams was a blatant lie.

You probably learned it in Seoul.

He recalled the city in a completely different realm, that he had visited with Lloyd before. Everything there was amazing and mysterious. Lights were still shining even during the night, and the tall buildings were out of this world.

The roads were so level and perfectly smooth despite its size. The tall buildings that reached the clouds in the sky were home to hundreds and thousands of people. It reminded me of apartment complexes back in the estate, but much larger.

That wasn't all. The underground was even more stunning. Throughout his stay in that futuristic settlement, Javier used his superhuman senses to hear

the sounds coming from beneath. Water was flowing through a pathway that was artificially created, suggesting that there was a complexly well-made pipeline of sewage.

And there was an even bigger pathway underneath, through which a carriage of a sort traveled very frequently, too.

The size of the tunnel was unfathomable, and a carriage was traveling, carrying thousands of passengers. So many citizens were benefiting from these public and private structures in one way or another, as though it was just a part of their everyday lives. Lloyd had definitely studied construction in a place like that.

But how did he end up here, and replace the real Master Lloyd?

That was a question that he couldn't possibly find the answers to. However, he had a rough idea.

Perhaps the enforced restoration of fate is somehow related to the fake Lloyd's secrets.

Perhaps that was the case. That most likely was the case. Javier was getting the feeling that it was the case. He wasn't suspecting it. He was almost sure.

He didn't know what to do. He did not know how to react to this, to help the fake Lloyd. Javier followed his master to the inner city with these thoughts in his mind.

The two men arrived at the countess's mansion and were granted an audience with the Young Lady of Namaran. In fact, Countess Siluria Namaran was now the official ruler of the city, having inherited the title. Having met her for the first time in a long time, Lloyd exchanged greetings with her and heard the detailed report about the mana explosions and slope crumbling down. But Lloyd only listened and did not say a single word about his findings on his way here, as though he had just arrived in the city and hadn't performed any inspections. After the meeting, he put down his belongings in the honored guest rooms, stirring Javier's curiosity.

“Are you by any chance suspecting Countess of Namaran?”

“Not at all,” replied Lloyd, shaking his head. He knew the countess was the last person he would suspect as the mastermind behind this whole incident.

Because she died in the original story, as a result of Namaran’s Wall. She was supposed to be the victim, and will most likely meet the same fate should we fail to put a stop to this scheme.

Lloyd had an idea as to how he was going to investigate this case already.

“We’ve been through a lot today, so let’s take a quick break. Aren’t you tired?”

“Of course I’m not—“

“We’re going to get extremely busy starting tomorrow. Can we go to sleep already?”

Javier put on a straight face and stared at Lloyd. His master was at it again, trying to make him go to sleep.

For what? Is he trying to leave his presence and disappear like last time?

Javier contemplated momentarily but decided to play along.

“Okay. Sing me the lullaby then.”

“Just open your ears already, because I’ve been ready.”

Lloyd began reciting the contents of his major textbook again, in the same, boring tone as that of the professor that led the sessions. Combined with complex knowledge and terminology, Javier’s eyelids began to fall slowly but surely. He was sound asleep in a few moments.

There.

Having confirmed it, Lloyd slowly got up and went inside the dressing room to change his clothes. He then activated the ending spoiler there,

summoning a blue portal in the corner. He took a good look at the new ending that was created, entailing what would transpire after the queen's left arm was cured. Lloyd left and let out a deep breath, with a satisfactory smile on his face.

"...I see. So this is what's going on."

He had just seen a new ending to this life and got an idea to put a stop to this tragedy. In fact, he drew a bigger picture than that.

Lloyd stepped out of his room immediately and went to meet with the Countess of Namaran, with the huge picture still in his mind. He did not hesitate to explain the best method to the countess.

"I know it may sound strange and even ridiculous, but we must evacuate every single citizen of Namaran from the city. Not a single soul is to remain."

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Chapter 375: Crushing Obstacles (3)

“I know it may sound strange and even ridiculous, but we must evacuate every single citizen of Namaran from the city. Not a single soul is to remain.”

“Pardon...?”

The current Countess of Namaran, who used to be the young lady of this city, paused wrapping up her duties for the day in her study and frowned.

“What do you mean by that?”

She was genuinely confused. She had just exchanged her greetings with Lloyd in the afternoon and expressed how glad she was about seeing him for the first time in a long time, as well as concerns about the signs of collapsing the cliff was showing. It had only been a few hours since then.

“Have you already identified the cause of the collapse?”

But the Lloyd she knew certainly was capable of coming to the conclusion this quickly. After all, he was the one who saved the city from dark mages and the hell’s knight. He had displayed unprecedented wits and composure to deliver Namaran unexpectedly, against all odds. And the new countess was right.

“Yes, I have.”

“Then there must be a reason why you want to evacuate all citizens of the city.”

“That is correct.”

“Would you be able to tell me?”

“Of course. Namaran’s Wall will be re-raised.”

“...What?” Countess of Namaran was visibly distraught as Lloyd continued.

“The incident will take place exactly at midnight of the sixth day from today. The stabilization piles installed underground will be moved through dark magic, forming a magical seal of a sort. A wall of magical energy will shroud the city again, and all lives within the barrier will perish.”

“That’s...”

“And the hell’s knight will awaken again, but in complete form this time.”

“...”

“The city will be destroyed, as well as other settlements in the vicinity due to the activity of the hell’s knight. That is what I am suspecting.”

“Did you obtain a prophecy by any chance?”

“No,” said Lloyd with a smile on his face. “I just happened to acquire a few key clues while I was investigating the scenes. I made deductions based on those, and came to this conclusion.”

That was a blatant lie; Lloyd had read the ending spoiler, according to which he had met a tragic fate.

I was murdered in cold blood by the hell’s knight.

Lloyd was away from Javier unfortunately in that moment, when he ran across the hell’s knight in its full powers. As a result of the clash in which Lloyd put up a decent fight, he came up short against the creature that was mightier than swordmasters. The hell’s knight ascending to Namaran was an elite boss with a name and the commander of the first division in hell’s army. There was no way Lloyd could overcome this beast. He fought valiantly, sang, and tried to buy time until Javier came to his rescue, but all to no avail. His body was ripped apart to pieces, and he met his tragic demise. He tried to stand his ground and lifted his shovel to counterattack, when his heart was pierced by the blade. That was roughly the ending he had seen through the spoiler this time.

Tsk. And it hurt like crap.

Lloyd inadvertently trembled like a leaf, having been reminded of the excruciating pain he felt as the blade found his heart. That was the problem with the ending spoiler; it was so real, that Lloyd felt every single feeling of the ending, including the pain.

“Anyhow,” continued Lloyd, brushing off the unnecessary thoughts. “All of us will be swept away by a tragic catastrophe if we don’t do anything.”

“What are the chances of that happening?”

“I would say a hundred percent.”

The Countess of Namaran bit her lips tightly. After Lloyd gave her some time to process this, she spoke again.

“Okay, I trust your words, because you’re the one that saved my father, and everyone in this city. But there is something I would like to ask.”

“I am listening.”

“Is evacuating all citizens the only way to respond to the tragedy?”

“I’m afraid it is.”

“Why? If it is indeed going to happen six days from today, I think that’s enough time to make other preparations.”

“Are you feeling uncomfortable about fleeing from the problem?”

“To tell you the truth, yes,” nodded the young countess. “It isn’t easy to make a city-wide announcement and force all citizens to evacuate immediately. The city is their home, and it would make me and the rest of the citizens feel like we haven’t tried enough to solve the issue.”

“I understand how you feel, but there is nothing for you to worry about.”

“Please elaborate.”

“Evacuating doesn’t necessarily mean running away.”

“Then you have another purpose.”

“Yes. We’re laying a trap.”

“...Trap?”

Countess of Namaran frowned, as the smile on Lloyd’s face became even more apparent.

“That’s right. We might as well get rid of the source of the problem, while we’re at it.”

“You want to lay a trap to exterminate the enemies.”

“Exactly.”

“Can you please enlighten me with the details?”

“Of course I can.”

Lloyd put a huge smile on his face, appreciating the countess’s trust. All that was left to do was explain the plan in detail, to win her support in all this. He approached the countess with confidence.

“Please allow me. This is something no one should eavesdrop on.”

“I’m all ears.”

“Okay, so the plan is... blah, blah... everyone will be safe... blah, blah... in the city hall... blah, blah...”

The young countess’s eyes became wider as Lloyd’s whispers continued. The next morning, the plan for all citizens to evacuate the city was announced.

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“Leave our homes and jobs and get out of the city all of a sudden? Just like that?”

“But they’re going to have tents for us to stay, Dad.”

“Tsk, are we supposed to be thankful for tents? What about our work?”

“It looks like that will have to be suspended. But they’ll be providing food.”

“Food? Okay, I’m bursting into tears because I’m so grateful. We will at least have food. Ha.”

“But Dad.”

“What?”

“The countess also stated this in the announcement.”

“What.”

“That this is the only way to keep everyone safe.”

“Safe?”

“Yeah.”

“From what?”

“From the slope that was showing signs of collapsing as of late. She said the entire city is to be emptied so that the inspection of the soil can be conducted.”

“Inspection of the soil?”

“Yeah.”

“And who’s going to do that?”

“Lord Lloyd Frontera.”

“What?!”

It was at the home of an ordinary family during breakfast. A single father of one daughter paused upon hearing this and asked his child again, in a cautious manner.

“Did you just say Lord Lloyd Frontera?”

“Yeah.”

The daughter nodded confidently, and the father’s grumbling attitude quickly subsided.

“I see. Hahahaha. So Lord Lloyd Frontera is going to do that for us?”

“Yeah. That’s what the announcement said.”

“Ahahaha. You should have told me that first. I wouldn’t have gotten upset.”

The single father burst out in laughter, quickly feeling embarrassed about his complaints against the order to evacuate.

“Then we must follow the order faithfully. When are we expected to leave?”

“It said the tents will be ready within five days.”

“Alright, then should we get started on packing after breakfast?”

“Okay, Dad.”

The single father picked up the bread to resume eating, and the daughter followed with a smile. Similar conversations took place all across Namaran, from old stables and shops getting ready to open for business, to the bedrooms of newlyweds and the barracks of guards. Every citizen of the estate was confused about the order to evacuate, with some asking genuine questions until they heard that Lloyd Frontera was involved. As soon as they found out Lloyd was going to conduct an inspection, they accepted it without question. It was obvious; that most citizens of Namaran considered themselves to be deeply indebted to Lloyd Frontera. This man was a

trustworthy individual. They all waited to be assigned to their tents, aside from a few who were skeptical about this order. They were mostly vassals in service of the countess.

“Lady Namaran, I don’t know what to say about this... but this is a bit strange.”

“What is?”

Countess of Namaran stopped eating and put down on fork, staring at the administrator, who had rushed to the countess’s mansion early in the morning to express his concerns.

“The order for all citizens that you had announced this morning. I was genuinely confused about it.”

“What do you mean?”

“I am skeptical about the inspection of the soil that Young Lord Lloyd Frontera is going to perform,” said the administrator, in an increasingly composed manner of speech. “I am aware of the problem that mysterious mana explosions and the collapsing ground have been posing as of late, and that we must come up with an action plan. Inspecting the soil underneath the city makes sense, too. However, does it require evacuating all citizens and emptying the city...?”

“You find that strange.”

“I do, Lady Namaran,” replied the administrator, nodding honestly. The Countess of Namaran chuckled and responded.

“I understand how you feel. Of course it is strange. I’m sure anyone would. However, we will all be in big trouble if we don’t follow the suggestions of Lloyd Frontera.”

“Huh? Are you saying that the inspection is just an excuse...?”

“I’m so relieved to have an administrator who’s quick-witted.”

“...”

“I can’t tell you everything at the moment, but the ground collapsing is just the sign of a much greater issue that’s hidden. Lord Lloyd Frontera identified the real problem, and suggested the evacuation to get rid of the source.”

“Then...”

“I have placed my trust in that man. And that’s why I need you.”

“I’m at your service.”

“Please go convince other vassals of the realm that now isn’t the time to argue, but to combine our efforts to solve this issue together. Understood?”

“...Of course. As you wish.”

The administrator came to ask questions but left persuaded. Half a day later, other subjects of the countess agreed with their lord and pledged their support. The order to evacuate the citizens picked up speed, and a huge camp outside of the city under the cliff was created. In five days, all tents were built and assigned to the citizens of the city, allowing them to relocate temporarily, including most of the cattle. The entire city was pretty much empty.

In the meantime, Lloyd filled the empty city with tens of thousands of insects and worms. He had thoroughly searched all forests in the vicinity as Countess of Namaran led the citizens out of the streets, capturing the likes of moths, grasshoppers, worms, and beetles with the help of Ggoming, the bird and natural bug hunter, and Javier, who had superhuman senses. Lloyd gathered an especially additional amount of detestable mosquitoes, before releasing them into the city. He then waited an entire day in the empty settlement. Having spent a quiet noon and ruddy afternoon, a moonlit sky of the night welcomed him. The stars were up in the northern skies towards midnight, during which a strange, unstable sign of a huge change showed.

Bzzzt... The stabilization piles installed in the cliff supporting the city unleashed nefarious light, forming a dark purple wall of magical energy that swirled ominously.

Whooooooosh! The nightmarish wall that stood with the intent to devour even the moon and the stars marked the beginning of the second Namaran's Wall incident.

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Rustle! The pouch moved violently. The opening was still sealed, so the beetles could only twitch around on the inside. Namaran's Wall emanated a strange vibe and absorbed the life energy of these insects, which struggled to resist amidst shrieking noises of agony. Other pouches were just the same. Thousands of grasshoppers, worms, and moths all fluttered their limbs and antennae, before losing their lives to the devastating wall. This life energy was all absorbed by Namaran's Wall, which refined it all and gathered it in a single place: the city hall of Namaran. The memorial stone in the center of the huge hall shook.

Crumble! The life forces came together, powered the ominous, evil energy at work, and broke the memorial stone that commemorated the end of the first Namaran's Wall incident.

Crush! A transcendent something opened its eyes from within the stone. It was the hell's knight, which had tasted defeat in this very place. It was the commander of the first corp of the freakish hell's army, Sir Giolexius, who had been beaten by Javier and Lloyd.

A black skeletal figure resurrected and came back from the realm between hell and eternal doom. He certainly looked different from his incomplete self before; his limbs were all intact, and a fearsome-looking armor covering his dark bones that glossed like obsidian let out the roars of the pure-evil grim reaper. The greatsword that ruled over the demons of the underworld unleashed scary clinking noises against air molecules.

"...My fight is not over yet."

Crush! Crush! Sir Giolexius lifted his head, breaking the memorial stone apart and glaring through baleful eyes that shone beneath the helm as he stepped forward. His eyes were full of grudges and disappointment from the previous fight. The commander of the first corp of hell's army was infuriated by the battle in which he was defeated and perished.

"It shall be different this time around, swordmaster Javier Asrahan and deceitful Lloyd Frontera. If you think you can stop me again, you're wrong."

Crush! He stretched out his hand, completely breaking the memorial stone. The evil commander placed his hand blessed with hellish, murderous powers on the floor of the city hall, which subsequently cracked apart like soil struck by drought.

"I have regained my complete form today. Swordmaster? I don't care. Challenge me.'

Kwoosh! Crush! He slowly lifted his upper body amidst the hell's flames that sparked near him. The fearsome atmosphere that would surely put pressure on any living creature spread around in the vicinity, as Sir Giolexius shouted out with his heart.

"Only a grandmaster, that does not exist in this world, can defeat me in this form! Javier Asrahan, come and face me so we may finish this once and for all!"

The hell's knight's confident statement did not go unheard. All of a sudden, a massively composed voice spoke out in a familiarly annoying manner from the knight's back.

"First time facing a grandmaster?"

"...What?"

Sir Giolexius was genuinely confused by the reply. He quickly turned around and saw what was coming at him, but it was too late when he

realized it. Grandmaster Javier’s nuclear slash was charging towards him with the intent to slice the entire galaxy in half.

Kwooosh!!

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Chapter 376: Hell’s Knight’s Hell (1)

Kwooooosh! The slash fell with the intent to slice the entire galaxy in half. There was no creation that could stop this attack or avoid it. The hell’s knight was literally screwed. That’s what Sir Giolexius thought as he saw Javier’s blade approach. However, being a commander in the hell’s army and an honorable knight, he attempted to launch a counteroffensive instead of fleeing.

“Hraah!”

Kwoosh! Sir Giolexius’s greatsword was shrouded in dark mist that could instantly send the poor victim’s soul and body to hell upon contact.

Kwoosh! It ignited like fire near the handle and extended to the blade, until the entire sword was covered in dark energy.

Thump! And then Javier’s slash smashed against Sir Giolexius’s head.

“Urgh.”

The hell’s knight’s head fell backwards as his entire ribcage, from number one to seven, all twitched violently as though they were part of the package. Sir Giolexius mumbled in the agonizing pain in a frustrated manner.

“My... dark powers...”

But Javier responded to murmuring words with another, even firmer slashing of his sword.

Clink! Thwoosh! Slash! Rib number three was pierced, his left pelvis was slashed, and right femur broke.

“Ugh... Ack!”

Sir Giolexius inadvertently let out a cry of pain. He couldn’t respond at all; it was supersonic speed that was on a whole new level, not to mention the

power of the slash. Each time he sustained the hit, it felt as if the affected body part had disappeared for good, although the hell's knight hadn't lost anything physically yet despite the excruciating pain. Instead, his armor was being deformed. It took Sir Giolexius two more thumps on his body to realize why his body wasn't breaking down or being sliced.

"Wait a minute... Your sword... is sheathed..."

The eyes of the first corp commander of hell's army shook violently, shortly before the sheath of Javier's sword flew again, whacking Sir Giolexius in the head.

Thump!

"Agh!"

The strike with a blunt object didn't only rattle his skull, but also left a humiliating frustration in his mind.

"How dare you keep your sword sheathed against me...!"

His ribcage twitched. He was a mighty hell's knight, and the first corps commander of the hell's army. There shouldn't have been anyone on earth that could withstand him. Not even swordmasters that humans took pride in could give him a challenge in battle. There was no one, aside from grandmasters that only existed in theory, that could stop him.

Ever since he was defeated in the previous battle, he constantly strengthened his resolve to exact revenge. He constantly prayed to the destiny to put him back on the battlefield against the humans that did this to him, in his complete form so he could restore dignity to his name, throughout the time a tiny fragment of his soul barely managed to linger around in the underworld. He patiently endured the humiliation and waited for the right time. And it had finally come. The destined fate had been altered by human intervention, and the gigantic flow was trying to restore it back to normalcy, resurrecting the hell's knight in this very place again. Sir Giolexius was overjoyed. He was determined to find Javier Asrahan and

challenge him to a fair duel, in which he was going to claim victory to regain his honor.

But the reality couldn’t be worse. The firm resolve he had harbored in his heart was breaking apart with each painful strike on his body.

“Ack! No...! Argh! No way...!”

Swoosh! Thump! Sir Giolexius’s skull turned 180 degrees with this smash, sending a tooth flying in the other direction. The hell’s knight saw in the heat of the moment and confirmed that it was indeed the sheath of the sword that smacked his face just now, destroying what was left of his pride as the knight from hell.

“Not an aura. Not a relic sword. At least draw your sword... Urgh!”

Swoosh! Thump! But the unsheathed sword of the grandmaster was so painful each time it struck. The hell’s knight found this absolutely frustrating. He couldn’t comprehend.

“But... how...?”

He couldn’t understand how Javier Asrahan had made so much progress while he was gone, when the human knight could barely keep up with the hell’s knight in his incomplete form. Sir Giolexius clearly had the edge over him despite missing an arm and a leg.

“I’ve ascended in my complete form. How?!”

Whoosh! Bam! The sheath flew at lightning speed and thumped the hell’s knight’s chest this time. Sir Giolexius was about to burst into tears, not because it hurt, but because he couldn’t accept the reality. He realized Javier had improved that much. Javier had exceeded his expectations and gained beyond the imaginable boundary of might. The hell’s knight thought how he could get out of this tight spot and ultimately regain his honor.

I must accept things as they are.

Bite! Sir Giolexius bit his lips and tightened the grip on his greatsword, resisting the ferocious attack by raising the dark aura around him. After taking a few hits, it was painfully obvious that Javier was far stronger than the hell's knight in his complete form. Perhaps he had really made the impossible breakthrough to become a grandmaster. He began to look at things in a different perspective.

Wait. This is a sacred and honorable battle against a mighty grandmaster, then!

His eyes lit up. There could not have been another hell's knight that faced a grandmaster. Sir Giolexius became ecstatic by the thought that he was the first one to walk this arduous path.

"Fine by me, grandmaster!"

Whoosh! Whoosh! He swung his greatsword shrouded in dark powers, encouraging himself and becoming spirited once again. The outcome of the battle did not matter to him anymore. The hell's knight was absolutely exhilarated by the fact that he was facing someone that would go down in history itself. Losing after going all out against a legendary adversary like Javier Asrahan was going to be an epic, honorable way to die. Having regained the passion, Sir Giolexius let out an even braver shout towards Javier.

"Hell's knight Giolexius, the commander of the first corp of hell's army, would like to challenge you to an epic duel—"

Bang! The sheath flew again and whacked Giolexius's mouth while he was still speaking, crushing his front teeth and sending them flying everywhere. Sir Giolexius himself was pushed back like a plastic bag against the gust and crushed into the wall of the city hall.

"Urgh!"

The hell's knight ceased to feel anything after it felt as though all of his joints were dislocated and put back in their original positions barely. But Sir

Giolexius endeavored to get up despite the lack of energy, lifting his head to glance at Javier.

“J-Javier Asrahan.”

Step. Step.

“So you do not intend to engage me in an honorable battle.”

Step. Step.

“Then stop dishonoring me and kill me right away. Draw your sword!”

Step. Step.

“What are you waiting for? Why do you appear reluctant to take my life? You must know how I feel, as a knight yourself! Slit my throat, unless you will engage me in a glorious battle!”

Sir Giolexius mustered all the energy that was left in him and let out a shout, causing Javier to stop.

Javier subtly frowned and loosened his grip slightly on his sword. He turned his gaze at Lloyd, who was watching with a smile on his face as a spectator.

Master Lloyd.

He signaled with his eyes.

Can I just end the fight already?

That was Javier’s true wish. Killing the hell’s knight in an instant was a walk in the park, and he believed it was the right thing to do.

But why would he want me to keep beating him until he loses all of his fighting spirit, without killing him...?

That was what Lloyd had instructed Javier prior to the battle. He was not to kill the hell’s knight, but to apprehend him alive. Not only that. Lloyd had

emphasized the importance of making the enemy lose the will to resist by beating the crap out of him, over and over.

I don't get it. Does he want something specific from the hell's knight?

But Javier glanced at Lloyd, silently asking for permission to grant the poor hell's knight a quick death, like a proper knight.

No, Lloyd firmly shook his head and denied the request. It was as if chivalry wasn't supposed to be alive, and Javier had to listen to Lloyd. Javier frowned and asked again in the same manner.

Is this really necessary?

Of course it is.

Lloyd shrugged his shoulders. As a matter of fact, this was absolutely necessary in Lloyd's perspective as he wanted to beat some information out of the hell's knight.

Killing him would be so easy for Javier. All he has to do is release a few slashes, and he'll dice him up like stew meat in an instant.

Lloyd wondered how many hell's knights it would take to stand against Javier. It would take at least thirty. Lloyd then proceeded to the next thought, putting the current one aside.

I'm only doing this because I saw the most recently updated ending spoiler.

He recalled what he saw in the newest ending spoiler, in which Lloyd faced the hell's knight alone while Javier was away. The battle against the hell's knight was lonely and arduous, and even hopeless as Lloyd had lost his life. But that wasn't why he had ordered Javier to whoop the hell's knight's butt. It was because of what he said before Lloyd lost his life in the ending spoiler.

"You finally meet your demise, Lloyd Frontera. But you should actually be grateful instead, because you're going to miss out on the real catastrophe that will strike your estate in the future thanks to me."

It was devastating. Lloyd had mustered whatever energy he could scrape to barely manage to ask what he meant by that, only to see the look of pity in the hell's knight's eyes alongside the response.

"The great king of hell has laid out a perfect plan that a maggot like you could never comprehend, let alone put a stop to."

And that was it. Lloyd's heart was pierced by the greatsword in the ending spoiler, preventing him from finding out more.

I must take advantage of this opportunity to hear more.

He felt iffy about just slaying the potential informant. In fact, Lloyd felt insecure.

The king of hell must be scheming something up right now, so as to bring destruction to my estate. I can't let that catastrophe strike.

Lloyd had taken a peek at his last moments through the ending spoiler, and it didn't take a rocket scientist to come to this conclusion. Lloyd couldn't accept the predetermined fate, and had come up with the plan to allow Namaran's Wall to be re-erected, evacuate the citizens, and to wait for the hell's knight to come back with just Javier by his side. His efforts were about to pay off, as the chance to interrogate his enemy was right around the corner.

I can't let this chance go. The grand plan by the king of hell is at least closely related to the enforced fate phenomenon and can even possibly present another opportunity to crush that damn phenomenon once and for all.

Although nothing was clear as of yet, Lloyd saw a glimpse of hope in this situation like a single ray of light shining through a tiny hole into the deep underground cave. That was why Lloyd took a step forward and approached the hell's knight on the ground, crouching down to make eye contact with him.

"It's been a while."

“...”

Sir Giolexius balefully glared at Lloyd, with hostility lingering in his eyes. Javier tightened his grip on the sword, preparing to crush his skull in time just in case the hell’s knight managed to get up and strike Lloyd, as his master put a fake smile on his face and continued.

“It looks like you wish not to speak with me.”

“...”

“Hmm. That’s a shame.”

“...”

“But you just asked Javier to grant you a quick, honorable death. Right?”

“...”

“I’m afraid I’m the one that can decide that.”

“...”

“You’re not going to die even if you want to, if you keep your mouth shut like that.”

“Kill me right now.”

“I refuse.”

“...”

Sir Giolexius grinded his teeth balefully as Lloyd’s smile deepened.

“There is a surefire way to get your wish granted. Just answer my questions.”

“Questions?”

“The king of hell. He’s up to something, isn’t he?”

“...”

“Tell me all you know.”

“...”

“So you won’t talk.”

“I don’t know anything.”

“Really?”

“That’s right.”

“Tsk. What a bummer. I suppose you think there is honor in lying.”

“All I want is honorable battle and death. Sharing my king’s secrets with enemies isn’t what a true knight does.”

Sir Giolexius’s eyes glowed ominously. He had just declared that he wouldn’t betray his lord as a knight chasing after honor, despite being from a realm full of trickery and dishonesty. However, the hell’s knight had failed to take into account Lloyd’s persistent and sketchy character.

“Really? Okay, then.”

Lloyd shrugged his shoulders at the solemn response by Sir Giolexius. The estate developer’s gaze soon turned into a rather nefarious one, however.

“I guess I’ll have to torture you until you spill the beans, then.”

“...What?”

“Let’s start with your sense of hearing.”

“What are you—”

“I’m sure you remember the singing lessons by Maestro Lloyd Frontera.”

Lloyd put a big smile on his face and held his shovel up like a microphone. Sir Giolexius’s face turned pale, as he obviously remembered what had happened in the past.

“W-wait!”

“Ahem. Mm. Ah. Ah. Testing the microphone. One and two and three and four.”

“H-hold on!”

The hell’s knight’s voice became desperate, but Lloyd did not care. He turned to Javier and mischievously rebuked him.

“Javier. What do you think you’re doing?”

“Huh?”

“Drop the beat box.”

“…”

That was how Lloyd’s merciless, ruthless, and inhumane torture session to draw out information from the hell’s knight began.

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Chapter 377: Hell’s Knight’s Hell (2)

Namaran, the city atop the cliff, was in absolute silence a little after midnight. Dark purple barrier of strange magical energy lit underneath the moonlight that shone ominously upon the streets, as an even more peculiar song, if it could be called that, broke the quietness of the night from the empty city hall in the center of the town with the intent to send the eardrums of anyone that heard it to the afterlife.

“Twinkle! Twinkle! Little! Star! How I! Wonder! What you are! Up above the world so high! Like a diamond in the sky!”

“Ugh...!”

“Twinkle! Twinkle! Little! Star!”

“D-don’t wonder...!”

“How I! Wonder! What you aaaaare!”

Lloyd’s outcry of a song filled the city hall. His voice was particularly strong and loud despite the lack of any musical knack, absolutely molesting the hell’s knight’s ears. Sir Giolexius, the commander of the first corp of hell’s army, struggled deeply with each word that came out of Lloyd’s mouth. He vented.

“Stop!”

“No.”

“Do you honestly think I will give in and speak?”

“Oh, I think you will.”

“...”

“Most definitely.”

“That will never happen.”

“We’ll see what happens. Ahem.”

The hell’s knight twitched his jaws in frustration as Lloyd cleared his throat, shortly before tilting his face sideways in an annoying manner.

“So you have no intention of telling me what the king of hell is scheming to accomplish as of yet. Is that correct?”

“I won’t!”

“I am so relieved to hear my dearest fan wants to keep listening to my songs.”

“Th-that’s...”

“Thank you so much. Shall I, then?”

“H-hold on!” Sir Giolexius shouted desperately, but the plea did not sway Lloyd’s heard a single inch in any direction whatsoever.

“Check this out. Five little monkeys jumping on the bed! One fell down and bumped his head!”

“...Urgh...!” Sir Giolexius shook his skull violently, but he couldn’t put up a resistance at all as Javier had begun to add beat into the terrifying nursery rhyme.

Bam! Bam! Badum-tss. Thump! Thump! The sheath of the grandmaster’s sword fell straight down, shrouded in rhythmic aura, on the hell’s knight’s head like percussion enriching any music.

“Argh! Therp! Ouch!”

The shock from the impact was immense, as Lloyd’s torturous song continued to rattle the hell’s knight’s ear drums.

“Mama called the doctor and the doctor said! No more monkeys jumping on the bed!”

“S-stop!”

“Stop?”

“Y-yes! Just stop it already...!”

“Then are you going to tell me what the king of hell is up to now?”

“Like I told you before, I am a knight bound by honor not to share the secret plans of my lord and liege!”

“Then keep listening to my songs.”

“What?!”

“Next song.”

“H-hold on!”

Sir Giolexius hurriedly stretched out his hands, only to be whacked in the arm by Javier’s strike.

Bam!

“Urgh!”

Knee to the jaws fell like an entire avalanche sweeping through his face. Sir Giolexius barely managed to stay awake and lifted his body from the ground with two hands, followed by deep regrets.

“Row, row, row your boat, gently down the stream! Merrily, merrily, merrily, merrily, life is but a dream!”

Bang! Bang! Bang! Javier smacked the crap out of the hell’s knight skull, along with the beat of Lloyd’s horrid performance.

“Row, row, row your boat, gently up the creek! If you see a little mouse, don’t forget to squeak!”

“Urgh...”

It felt as if he was rowing his boat across the River Styx each time Lloyd let out another word out of his mouth. Sir Giolexius desperately wished to lose his consciousness, dropping the hellish glow on his down like teardrops down his cheeks. But Lloyd’s massively destructive performance continued, this time with a gently abysmal choice of song with the intent to comfort the little poor soul from hell, accompanied by off-pitch notes.

“You better watch out! You better not cry! You better not pout! I’m telling you why! Why! Santa Claus is coming! To town!”

“...”

The hell’s knight would rather cry out in agony right now, but couldn’t due to the sheath of Grandmaster Javier rattling his skull rhythmically to enrich the distasteful performance.

“He’s making a list, and checking it twice!”

Bam! Bam! Badumt-ss. Thump! Thump!

“Gonna find out! Who’s naughty or nice!”

Badum-tss.

“Urgh! Argh! Ack!”

The fierce beating of the skull genuinely made Sir Giolexius wonder who this Santa Claus was, but he knew one thing for sure: who was naughty. There was one individual clearly naughtier and more evil than the king of hell.

“Ugh... Stop! Enough!” Sir Giolexius cried out, failing to endure the physical and aural violence manhandling him simultaneously. His entire body shivered.

Perhaps the cry for help was heard by the god, as Lloyd finally stopped his concert that was as horrendous and filthy as the buzzing sound of flies over rotting food in the trash can.

“Enough? For real?”

“Huff... Huff... Thank you...”

“Too early to say that,” Lloyd replied with a halfway smile, asking the hell’s knight in a cold voice. “So, are you finally ready to tell me what I want to hear?”

“Th-that’s...”

“Go on.”

“I am a knight. I can’t...”

“Wrong answer.”

“H-hold on!”

“Ahem. One, two, one, two, three, go!”

“Stop!”

“What.”

“N-no. Please don’t sing...”

“You want me to stop singing.”

“...Right,” Sir Giolexius nodded and replied in a resentful voice. “The worst song I thought I had ever heard was sung by the choir of angels, until I heard your performance today.”

“Thank you so much. You flatter me.”

“You can physically torture me in any other way you desire. I’ll endure it silently. So Please just stop singing.”

“No.”

“But it’s massively agonizing! Not just my ears, but it feels like my entire honor and pride as a knight are being overlooked upon! I don’t know if you know this or not, but I am a knight from hell, who has sworn an oath to live or die by blood and fire of the battlefield!”

“Okay, so what?”

“But your song... is literally crushing all that down! It’s as if you don’t acknowledge me as a proud knight! It’s massively humiliating.”

“But you didn’t find it humiliating to serve a liege that didn’t do anything for you in exchange for your blind loyalty?”

“What?” Sir Giolexius paused. Lloyd put a bigger smile on his face.

“Think about it. The king of hell isn’t a great liege.”

“What the hell are you talking about?”

“Your lord and liege? But what did he do to earn your loyalty? Did he offer you any benefits?”

“Benefits...?”

“Those are your rights at a workplace, as a professional that gets paid to work.”

“What are you trying to get at...?”

Sir Giolexius’s eyes shook as Lloyd Frontera spoke of confusing things that did not make sense to him at all. But the estate developer did not care; he continued to elaborate in an eloquent manner.

“I will tell you what I’m trying to get at. Have you ever gone home immediately after your shift was supposed to be over?”

“Shift...?”

“Yeah. Have you ever?”

“There is no such thing as a shift for a knight. I am sworn to protect my liege day and night. I don’t even have a home to return to.”

“You don’t have a home?!”

“Of course not. Those things are meaningless for a hell’s knight.”

“Tsk, tsk. You are a really poor soul,” said Lloyd, with a look of genuine compassion in his eyes. But before the hell’s knight could reply, he added a pitiful, yet empathetic statement to shake him further. “What about insurance?”

“...What?”

“Insurance. Dental, medical, liability and stuff. What if you get hurt while you’re working and require medical attention? Who takes care of that?”

“Of course—”

There was none. The hell’s knight had never heard of anything like that in hell. Sir Giolexius became speechless at the realization nothing like that was ever discussed or assured, as Lloyd sharply continued to point out the flaws of the system he was in.

“There’s none, right? What happens, then, if you return to hell after getting battered like this? Do you not get any monetary compensation for the risks you undertook? Seriously?”

“That’s—”

“That’s terrible. The king of hell is a terrible man.”

“Don’t you dare insult—”

“Just look. How can I not, when he’s not fulfilling his duty as anyone’s liege?”

“...”

“Think about it. Let me at least hear you get to go on vacation from time to time.”

“...”

“No way.”

“...”

“Are you being serious? No vacations, either?”

“N-no.”

“Holy moly. That’s just outrageous. What about paid leave? Sick leave?”

“Wh-what are even those?”

“You’ve never even heard about those.”

“N-no.”

“Oh. My. Goodness. Tsk, tsk.”

Lloyd let out a sigh and shook his head in disbelief, causing Sir Giolexius to feel a bit cheated for some reason. He thought he may have been a little naïve in the way he took care of himself in the workplace. It felt as though he could have been deprived of benefits that were rightfully his. And Lloyd was quick to notice the change of looks on the hell’s knight’s face like a witty guy he was. He continued to entice the hell’s knight with sugar-coated words.

“That’s just wrong. He did you wrong.”

“I...”

“I know how you feel. You feel cheated. You’re disappointed. After all the trouble you went through to carry out the missions you were given, too. The feeling that you were just being used and abused like an expendable tool. But let me tell you what.”

“Wh-what?”

“Your feelings are not wrong.”

“...”

“Every human... even if you’re not one, has some kind of rights even if you work for someone else. Even if you receive a fat paycheck every month, you still have the right to receive the benefits that are supposed to be given.”

“P-paycheck?”

“Hold up.”

“...”

“You’re not even getting paid?”

“Th-the knight from hell does not fight for money, but for honor—”

“Screw your honor. There’s no such thing as dignity or pride without actual monetary means to back them up.”

“...”

“What. The. Hell. Even if you love putting in extra efforts to make your organization grow, you must take at least minimum wage! From what you told me, you work all day and all night without taking a break, meals or lodging benefits, vacation, insurance, or pay! The king of hell absolutely cheated you!”

“D-don’t you dare say stuff like that against my liege!”

“Yeah, yeah. I know he’s your liege, and I know he brainwashed you to believe that he has the right to exploit you because he’s the king.”

“...”

“Really? You call someone like that your liege? What do you think, Javier?” Lloyd took a glance at Javier, who immediately understood what he was trying to get at and replied.

“That’s the worst kind of liege any honorable knight could have.”

“You think so, too?”

“Yeah. I am a knight in your service as well, but I get my pay and benefits from you, my lord.”

“Of course you do, because those are your rights as someone that works for anyone.”

“I agree with you.”

“...”

Lloyd and Javier passed around the basketball like prime Golden State Warriors looking for the open man to shoot, causing Sir Giolexius to anxiously pout. He had never doubted that it was his duty to offer his king and liege blind loyalty and selfless efforts. He wanted to refute Lloyd’s claims undermining his honor and pride that he had worked so hard to build, for the lack of monetary compensation or benefits. But he couldn’t. His heart still demanded absolute faith in the king of hell, but a small fragment of rationality in him was whispering to his ears.

I...

The hell’s knight had been mistreated, but still gave his one hundred percent to serve the king of hell, who had been, in fact, using his loyalty to his advantage.

“I...”

As soon as Sir Giolexius came to this realization, his entire body twitched in both mental and physical agony. He bled from his mouth as he struggled to reply.

“Perhaps there is a little bit of truth in what you say.”

“Tsk, Tsk. I know how difficult it is to acknowledge this, but you’ve done well.”

“N-no... Perhaps I’ve known this somewhere deep inside my heart for a long time.”

“It’s okay. You’ve been through a lot, being mistreated and exploited.”

“Ugh... Why did I...?”

“Tsk, tsk. Stop crying, dude. You didn’t do anything wrong.”

“B-but I...”

“It’s really okay. Think about it. How is it even your fault? All you did was try to offer your everything to make things better for your employer. There’s nothing wrong with doing your absolute best in a given situation. It’s his fault to have taken advantage of your good heart and exploited you.”

“D-do you think so?”

“Absolutely.”

It was that moment Lloyd knew the hell’s knight had been swayed to his cause. He was definitely ready to open up his heart and share the little secrets he had been reluctant to share. After winning him over completely, the information about the king of hell was going to be finally given. Lloyd clenched his fist with confidence at the sign of success, maintaining the compassionate look on his face and nodding empathetically at the troubled hell’s knight. He added in a soft, gentle voice.

“Be proud of yourself. Lift up your chin, because you are a good and honorable man. You do not deserve to work for a scoundrel like him.”

“Th-then...”

“You want to know what you need to do now, then. You have no idea what you’re supposed to do now.”

“...”

“Perhaps I can tell you. Do you want to hear?”

Sir Giolexius nodded with a heavy heart. It was time for Lloyd to seal the deal with a final move.

“It’s simple. Let’s write up a contract.”

Flap! Lloyd took out a contract that he had drafted in advance from his inner pocket, addressing the shift hours, meal and lodging, benefits including vacation and insurance, and monetary compensation in detail. It was a real, official work contract.

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Chapter 378: Hell’s Knight’s Hell (3)

“It’s simple. Let’s write up a contract.”

Flap!

“...What?”

Sir Giolexius confusedly stared at the document Lloyd took out. The hell’s knight couldn’t help but think this wasn’t a normal piece of paper.

“Contract...?”

“Yeah. Your employment contract.”

Flap! Lloyd took out another employment contract from his inner pocket and placed it next to the one he previously did, right on the floor between himself and the hell’s knight.

“These two are actually identical. One copy is for me and the other for you to keep, in order to prevent one party from changing the already established terms and conditions behind the other party’s back.”

“What is even an employment contract...?”

“You mean you don’t know?”

“I do have an idea. Does this mean I will be in your service after signing this?”

“Yeah.”

“...”

“Do you not like the idea?”

Sir Giolexius remained silent, causing Lloyd to shake his head.

“Tsk, tsk. Don’t you wish to work while being compensated properly? I thought you were upset because you were being mistreated the whole time.”

“Th-that’s true.”

“Allow me to rectify your situation.”

Tap. Tap. Lloyd tapped the employment contract on the floor with his palm twice, while looking straight into the hell’s knight’s face.

“I won’t say much to persuade you. Just read the content of this document, and sign it if you like it.”

“And if I don’t like it?”

“Then tell me which part you are not very comfortable with, so we can compromise and come to an agreement in that particular area prior to signing the contract. Both parties must be satisfied.”

“...”

Sir Giolexius was speechless. He was astounded by the fact that the terms and conditions could be revised and that he could point out areas he didn’t like. The hell’s knight then proceeded to read the contract draft and skimmed through.

“Dude, read it in detail. Don’t just skim through and sign it without understanding everything on the contract, because I hate guys that complain later about the terms and conditions after signing it,” Lloyd grumbled.

“Uh, o-okay,” Sir Giolexius replied and began to thoroughly read through the draft. It was even more astounding to see it in detail.

What...? I’ll be given a private room to stay...? And I can request a new place if I don’t like it?

Sir Giolexius was visibly shaken. There was no such thing as a tent, let alone a private room in hell. He had spent each night there by digging up a hole to lie down where lava wasn’t flowing at best.

What about the compensation?

The salary was suggested in human currency, which the hell's knight had no idea about, but it was supposedly three times that of a regular knight according to Lloyd, with the promise of incentives in the event of excellent performance that contribute to the prosperity of the estate. Furthermore, participation in certain projects within the estate could earn him extra pay for overtime and inclement weather conditions.

This is... so meticulous. And he's willing to pay for all medical expenses should I get injured while working?

These were only some of the benefits guaranteed in the contract, not to mention the actual work hours, after which the knight could go home and do whatever he wished to do. And that wasn't all.

"What's this?" Sir Giolexius pointed at another clause stated on the draft and began focusing on it. "I don't think I understand this part. The contract can be renewed every five years...? What does this mean?"

"Oh, that," Lloyd replied with a huge smile on his face, explaining the obvious. "It is as it says. The contract you sign today will be effective for five years."

"And what happens after that?"

"The contract is renewed."

"Why the hassle?"

"Because changes could be made to the contract."

"Are terms and conditions going to get worse?"

"That depends on how you do, but those normally get better for the employee. And if you don't like the new terms and conditions, you can always decline to sign."

"Really...?"

“Yeah,” Lloyd nodded. In fact, the draft Lloyd showed the hell’s knight wasn’t for a permanent position.

I can’t offer him a permanent position just yet. I’m only trying to win over his heart in order to hear what the king of hell is scheming behind everyone’s back.

Lloyd didn’t have too much information about the knight’s personality, lifestyle, or tendency to cause trouble when working with others in the estate yet. He was reluctant to offer something more substantial.

“Think of the first five years as a time to get to know each other better. You may or may not like working for me. Don’t you think so?”

“Hmm. I think you make a fair point.”

“See?”

“Yeah.”

Sir Giolexius nodded his skull. He now understood what the contract length was referring to after Lloyd’s thorough explanation. It was actually touching for him, because nobody has ever treated him this well.

And here I thought all I can offer was to fight, kill, and die as I am ordered around without receiving anything in exchange.

The hell’s knight had thought that was how everyone lived, but it turned out that wasn't the case. He realized he certainly did not have to do that, and that he could be rewarded for his efforts and time. He was supposed to, in fact. He had been cheated. As soon as he came to that realization, the hell’s knight made a decision.

“Fine,” said Sir Giolexius, nodding his skull again. “I will sign the contract.”

The hell’s knight took the pose he was so comfortable with, by kneeling on one knee to swear fealty. But Lloyd stopped him with a confused look on his face.

“What the hell are you doing?”

“Huh?”

“You use the pen to put your signature on the document to seal the contract, not prostrate.”

“Signature?”

“Yeah. I explained to you before. You sign the contract.”

Lloyd put another smile on his face and took out his pen, which the hell knight stared at blankly. He took the pen and gripped on it rather awkwardly.

“Wh-where do I put that?”

“Do you see the empty space on the bottom?”

“Yeah.”

“There.”

“How...?”

“Write down your name.”

“Like this?”

“Well done. Sign on this copy the same way.”

“Hmm. It’s not easy, because I haven’t written anything in a while.”

“It’s okay, you’re doing great. Are you done? Then lay one copy halfway over the other so as to slightly overlap them, and put your name on it once again. Just like that. Good.”

Scribble! Hell’s knight Sir Giolexius completed putting his signatures on the documents under Lloyd’s encouragement.

“Great. I will keep this copy, and you hold on to that one. Huh? Wait. I didn’t know your name was this long.”

“Giolexius. Is it too difficult for you to pronounce?”

“Hmm. I think it would be great if you had a nickname that was shorter.”

“I do have one, but it sounds too terrifying and fearsome, befitting my character. Even the demons in hell were afraid to call me this.”

“What is it?”

“Lexi.”

“...”

Lloyd genuinely wondered if the demons in the underworld found this nickname too cringeworthy to even bring up. And the hell’s knight Sir Giolexius knelt down on one knee and stretched out his hands before Lloyd could even respond in the meantime, holding one of Lloyd’s hands and slowly leading it towards his helm.

“Since I signed the contract, I shall serve you as my master from today,” said Lexi, despite the fact that the contract was set to expire five years later. Lexi had decided to serve Lloyd as his lord and liege until the contract was over. Even though the form was different, it wasn’t too far from the swearing fealty to the king. He strengthened his resolve internally, to offer loyalty and faith for the next five years.

A new message popped up.

Ding Dong!

[Approval Rating Unlocked]

[Hell’s Knight Sir Giolexius, Commander of the 1st Corp of Hell’s Army, was deeply touched by the employment contract.]

[Hell’s Knight Sir Giolexius was genuinely astounded by the fair and reasonable working conditions and employment terms that he had never experienced before, and strengthened his resolve to serve you faithfully.]

[Hell’s Knight Sir Giolexius is now in your service.]

[You are now able to increase Approval Rating with Hell’s Knight Sir Giolexius and obtain RP.]

[You have earned 50 RP as a bonus for unlocking a new character Approval Rating.]

[Current RP: 7,121]

[Hell’s Knight Sir Giolexius’s Approval Rating of you increased by 77.]

[Current Approval Rating with Hell’s Knight Sir Giolexius: +37]

[You have earned 847 RP thanks to a huge increase in the Approval Rating.]

[Current RP: 7,968]

Holy.

Bombarded with messages that popped up in front of his eyes, Lloyd nearly lost his composure and burst out in laughter. He couldn’t believe that the approval rating with the hell’s knight was unlocked, and he could gain RP by increasing it.

I can’t believe I can now become friends with the hell’s knight.

He was dumbfounded but felt great, as he was taking steps to reach his ultimate goal for the day.

Since he swore fealty to me, he won’t lie to me about the king of hell and what he’s up to. But I should set things straight before moving on.

Lloyd looked down at hell's knight Sir Giolexius, who was still prostrating like a faithful knight in service of the king. He was going to even lick his boots at this rate.

Ugh. This is so uncomfortable.

Lloyd shook off the awkward atmosphere and spoke.

"Hello? Sir Lexi?"

"I am at your service, my lord and liege."

"You're making me feel uncomfortable."

"I beg your pardon?" said Sir Giolexius, looking up to Lloyd in awe.

"It's too early for you to offer your blind loyalty yet," said Lloyd with a bitter smile on his face. "We're not there yet. You're not a permanent employee right now."

"Huh?"

"Start offering me your loyalty after you get a permanent position. Understood?"

"Permanent position...?"

"Yeah. Let's do our best for the next five years to make the next contract a permanent one. Okay?"

"As you wish, my lord," said Sir Giolexius, bowing down before Lloyd with the hopes that the next contract could be a permanent one. It was like a single ray of light shining down on him in darkness. It was strange and unfamiliar, but certainly heartwarming and encouraging.

"There is something I must speak of, my lord," added the hell's knight.

"What is it?" Lloyd replied.

“It’s about what you asked before.”

“Okay, please go into detail.”

“I will, my lord,” Sir Giolexius bowed, putting a satisfactory smile on Lloyd’s face. But the estate developer’s heart pouted at the same time; he felt anxious and concerned.

Just what the hell is he planning to accomplish?

The schemes by the king of hell were particularly difficult to predict, and that gave Lloyd a massive disadvantage in making appropriate preparations. Perhaps Sir Giolexius understood his new lord’s feelings, as he carefully and cautiously opened his lips.

“In order to explain in detail, I must refresh your memory about a certain event. Do you by any chance remember the sorcerer by the name of Lupellan?”

“Huh?” Lloyd was stunned.

Lupellan? Who was that?

Lloyd swam through the sea of his memory for a time and barely managed to remember someone by that name.

“Isn’t that the name of an evil sorcerer I slew back in the eastern mountains?”

Lloyd took a quick glance at Javier, who just remembered the incident that transpired way earlier. Lloyd continued.

“I got rid of that guy with the help of Javier before. I think that was when I created ice storehouses for the orc villages. A few of my guys in the engineering corps were kidnapped by that mage, so I attacked his base, killed that bastard, and saved my guys. But what about him, though? Is he related to what’s going to happen in any way?”

“That is correct, my lord,” nodded Sir Giolexius, before he proceeded to ask another question in a more solemn voice. “Do you also remember someone by the name of Neumann?”

“I definitely do,” Lloyd replied right away, without trying to remember this time. “He was a traitor that worked together with fraudsters. He got caught red-handed by me when he was selling off information about our estate.”

Sir Neumann, the traitor, was the senior knight in Lord of Frontera’s estate when he was still a baron. He commanded a group of knights including Javier, before being exposed.

“He lost to me and got squashed by Ppodong, before getting exiled from the estate covered in injuries. What about him, though?”

Lloyd frowned in confusion. Something wasn’t right. Something was amiss. Both Lupellan and Sir Neumann were people that were long lost in his memories. They were minor villains that caused trouble not long after he found himself in the body of Lloyd Frontera. They were defeated in the end and since then completely removed from the picture.

Why were they even mentioned just now, though? I don’t think they were related in any way.

Something was definitely up. Sir Giolexius opened his lips again as Lloyd was lost in thoughts.

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Chapter 379: How to Go Against Destiny (1)

“Lord Lloyd,” said Giolexius, slowly and cautiously confirming Lloyd’s suspicions. “They have been intertwined together without your knowledge, due to the flow of causality.”

“Intertwined...?”

“Yes, my lord,” the hells’ knight continued. “First, when you and Sir Javier slew Lupellan, you probably believed he had died for good. In reality, however, he had only lost his physical body and his soul traveled around in this realm.”

“Like an apparition with a grudge.”

“Yes, my lord. It must be because his desire to continue existing was far greater than anyone could imagine.”

“...”

Lloyd became speechless. He thought about the incident in which he killed the evil sorcerer and dark mage Lupellan, and admitted that the villain certainly exhibited such character. His reaction wasn’t that of someone that just didn’t want to die, but that of someone that had to survive at all costs in order to bring back his dead wife and children. His work on dark magic wasn’t completed. It was that kind of desperation.

Tsk. And sacrificing other innocent people just to bring back your dead family is okay? Give me a break.

Lloyd was disgusted by the hypocrisy of the man that supposedly was that immensely desperate to keep living.

So selfish and inconsiderate. His dead wife and children can’t come back to life if he dies? That’s not even a special excuse that only he has. Millions of fathers across the world are trying their best to put food on the table and take care of their wives and children. They strengthen their resolve every

time they wake up and go to work because they feel responsible for their family.

Lloyd snorted as Sir Giolexius continued.

“Anyhow, he used that desperation to drive him and became an apparition, instead of going to the underworld. That itself wasn’t too big of a deal, as apparitions are not that rare.”

“Then?”

“The problem was that he was an apparition with great knowledge about dark magic.”

“Hmm... Wait.”

“Are you getting a rough idea?”

“Yeah. Perhaps he found a suitable tool of an individual.”

“That is exactly where I was going, my lord,” Sir Giolexius nodded. “Lupellan’s apparition traveled around in this world and thought of ways to come back to life. Since he had the desperation and the knowledge, all he needed was a good tool. And he found just that.”

“...Please don’t tell me that’s Sir Neumann.”

“I’m afraid it is.”

“How did that happen?”

“It was all a huge coincidence, unless they were somehow predestined to meet. Anyhow, Sir Neumann had become a living corpse after sustaining grave injuries all over his body and being exiled. The physical disability to have difficulty even to lift his spoon to eat, along with the mental trauma from the event, drove him completely mad. He barely maintained himself, only to reiterate the same thing, that he will kill Lloyd Frontera one day, over and over. That he’d rather die if it can’t be done. That’s when Lupellan’s soul ran into this man.”

“...”

Lloyd bitterly bit his lips. It was a terrible coincidence, or a tragic flow of fate. He was particularly agitated by the fact that both Lupellan and Neumann harbored immense grudge against him.

“It was the meeting between the soul of the dark mage that lost his body, and the exiled knight that lost his soul,” Sir Giolexius continued. “It didn’t take them long to realize that their grudges were towards the same person.”

“So they became one.”

“To be precise, Lupellan destroyed Neumann’s soul and took over his body.”

“Tsk. I suppose that’s what an evil sorcerer would do.”

“What he did afterwards was also befitting.”

“What did he do?”

“He did not exhibit any signs hinting he had taken over Neumann’s body. He continued acting like a madman and receiving care from his family, while making one preparation at a time in order to bestow strength to his messed up body.”

“Wait. Hold up.”

“Did you get another rough idea as to what happened next?”

“Yeah, but it’s a terrible one. Did he by any chance use Sir Neumann’s family as sacrifices...?”

“I regret to tell you he did.”

“...”

Lloyd became speechless again, as Sir Giolexius went on.

“On the first night on which the old moon was up in the sky after he gained a new body, Lupellan performed a dark magic ritual that he had prepared discreetly over time. He summoned the demon of gluttony from hell and offered Neumann’s family as sacrifices. The demon of gluttony enjoyed the meal and offered a little bit of health to Lupellan in return, just enough so as to enable him to walk again, albeit with a limp.”

One horrific deed after another was revealed, as the evil plan lying beneath showed itself.

“Since he could move on his own, he started modifying his physical body little by little based on all he knew about dark magic. Then he finally reached the peak of physical modification through dark magic; he became a lich.”

“Tsk.”

Lloyd shook his head. He knew very well what a lich was, as this creature was mentioned in the novel *The Knight of Blood and Iron* as well.

Lich is an evil sorcerer that became an undead by abandoning humanity and vitality himself. It’s an undead archmage, so to speak. Its body will keep coming back to life despite being slain numerous times, with an endless supply of mana.

A lich was as powerful an adversary as a hell’s knight. Lloyd couldn’t believe an evil sorcerer he had slain became a massively annoying enemy to deal with, and began harboring this question.

“Hold on a second. I can’t help but think you mentioned this because this is somehow related to what the king of hell is planning. Correct?”

“That’s right, my lord,” said Sir Giolexius, with sparkling eyes. “Lupellan did not forget his ultimate goal even after becoming a lich. It is to exact revenge on you, my lord.”

“What happened to resurrecting his wife and children?”

“He lost a good chunk of humanity as he became a lich. I suspect his desperate desire to bring them back to life disappeared along with it.”

“And he was only left with the grudge against me.”

“Yes, my lord. And he chose to go with the surest way to get his wish.”

“And what would that be?”

“He expended all of his mana to get an audience with the king of hell, and asked him to open the hell’s gate to send reinforcements.”

“Hell’s gate? Reinforcements?”

“Yes, my lord. The hell’s gate is to open on Frontera Estate, unleashing an army of hell’s soldiers to sweep it.”

“...”

It sent chills down Lloyd’s spine and shut him up. Lloyd finally grasped the gravity of the situation.

Dark mage Lupellan. He really laid this out carefully.

Lloyd could guess that the lich had performed surveillance over the estate discreetly, coming to a conclusion.

He probably thought he could still lose despite having become a lich. Which isn’t difficult to imagine because of Javier. Even if Javier accompanies me outside of the estate, the dragon Solitas is there, and the angel Raphael recently settled in the estate, not to mention the dragon king Verkis in the guest chamber.

A single lich couldn’t dare attack the estate alone. That was probably why he asked the king of hell for reinforcements.

“And what did the king of hell say? He accepted the request?”

“Yes, my lord. There was no reason for him not to,” said Sir Giolexius promptly. “As you are already aware, the king of hell wishes you dead so he could keep you by his side. But you somehow manage to overcome one life-threatening situation after another, and that’s probably been getting on his nerves.”

“And a certain lich from this realm requested an audience and asked for reinforcements.”

“Exactly, my lord. That gave the king of hell a great cause to deploy his forces above ground.”

“I see. That would make it look like he’s only answering the request by the lich to send an army, instead of attacking without a just cause. Jeez.”

Lloyd took a deep breath, having finally realized what was going on and how the dark sorcerer he had gotten rid of way long in the past was related to the king of hell.

Come to think of it, it could be an event that could trigger the enforced fate phenomenon. It’s a new form of it.

He was reminded of the applicable arc within the novel *The Knight of Blood and Iron,* in which evil mage Lupellan was supposed to appear towards the latter part of the story. He was a hideous individual that sacrificed thousands of innocent lives through nefariously powerful dark magic and through sheer will on bringing back the dead. He would go on to destroy a few cities and settlements, causing massacres everywhere he went.

But here, he got caught by me and Javier before he could work on anything.

He had died in this world way earlier in comparison to the novel, and did not have a chance to wreak havoc. Lloyd had thought he did a good job by getting rid of a potential threat before it could grow, and he had taken pride in the fact he saved innocent lives from pre-determined massacres.

In reality, all such actions had caused the destiny as per the original story to go wayward, eventually causing the enforced restoration of fate to affect

Lupellan's fate as well.

Dark mage Lupellan, who had lost his life way before he was supposed to, was brought back to life by a mysterious flow of fate. The lich that returned was about to cause massacres Lloyd had prevented from happening.

He was an adept dark sorcerer in the story, but is now a lich. He was supposed to wreak havoc elsewhere, but is about to raze the Frontera Estate. The army of ghouls and zombies he had raised in the novel has been replaced by the army from hell.

Although the details were different, bigger events were just as the original story offered. In terms of horridness and the scale of the tragedy, it was even more catastrophic.

And what would happen after the Frontera Estate is razed down to ashes and everyone there dies? That would yield a result very close to the one the enforced fate phenomenon intends to bring about.

Lloyd was convinced now. The incomplete reset by the enforced fate phenomenon had been wanting Count of Frontera and his wife to suffer death all along, as well as those of Julian, Scheherazade, the Sultan and the Young Lady of Namaran, all of whom were supposed to die in the original novel.

Attacking the Frontera Estate could accomplish all of that in one act, returning the fate and history of those that were saved by my intervention to where they're supposed to be.

Lloyd felt more chills down his spine at the thought of it. He couldn't help but think that this forced restoration of destiny was more persistent and meticulous than he had anticipated. He was reminded of what the king of hell had recently told him.

He said the enforced fate phenomenon will come at me at an even greater force, the more I try to resist it, like a crashing of waves that consecutively gets more powerful, eventually bringing an unstoppable tsunami.

He recalled the look on the king of hell's face, showing absolute confidence in Lloyd's eventual demise despite the endeavors to stop the approaching fate.

Bite. Lloyd grinded his teeth bitterly.

But if you honestly thought I was going to give up here, you're absolutely wrong.

Lloyd was determined not to. He couldn't surrender. Not here.

Not after all I've done to survive!

In fact, he had literally climbed from the very bottom, enduring the stay in a tiny room full of mold and bugs in South Korea, the status of a country nobleman with an immense amount of debt, and an abundance of dust from endless constructions. He had made contributions to the royal court of the kingdom, which were finally recognized by the queen. Lloyd and his family's future was about to be secured for the rest of his life very soon. The life of a bum with status, power, and wealth, which he had dreamt of achieving for a very long time, was right around the corner.

This is basically the last obstacle.

Lloyd could live in absolute luxury as long as he could take care of this problem for good. But this particular matter seemed like an insurmountable wall. Even if he were to overcome it, there always could be another one waiting for him. Because he couldn't even imagine how much worse the next one was going to be, Lloyd came to this conclusion.

I must finish this once and for all.

He was determined to put an end to it regardless of what it took, this time.

It's already getting out of hand. The attack on the Frontera Estate itself is huge, but I should be able to stop it somehow if I scrape together the resources to focus on it. However, I have zero confidence against the next

one that attempts to restore destiny. That's why I must put a stop to it this time.

The wheel of fate that continuously and persistently chased after Lloyd Frontera, as well as the greed displayed by the king of hell, had to be destroyed. Lloyd suspected he couldn't keep fending it off one at a time. The greatest estate developer thought of what he could predict, carefully laid out what he was capable of, took many different options into account, looked for hopes here and there, and continued devising tactics and strategies to overcome the hardship. After a series of calculations and weighing of situations, he finally came to this conclusion.

"Ha," Lloyd let out a chuckle and took a glance at Javier and Sir Giolexius. "It's going to be a walk in the park."

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Chapter 380: How to Go Against Destiny (2)

“It’s going to be a walk in the park.”

Lloyd put a smile on his face, convincing himself to think this way. In fact, it didn’t take him long to come up with a solution anyways. But the estate developer noticed the looks from Javier and Sir Giolexius, and opened one eye wider than the other in response.

“What. Why are you two staring at me like that?” Lloyd grumbled.

“I was wondering what kind of outrageous scheme you have in your mind this time, and I was also genuinely concerned,” said Javier immediately, as though the silver-haired knight was waiting for Lloyd to say something. “But it looks like we’re in dire need of a plan, no matter how outrageous it may sound. I really had no idea the evil sorcerer we got rid of would turn out to be the cause of this much nuisance.”

“That’s what I’m saying. I really didn’t expect him to request the support of the king of hell.”

“So, let’s hear the easy method.”

“You’ll find out soon enough,” said Lloyd with a mysterious smile. “You’ll realize it back in our estate, after we wrap things up here. Alright, Gio... I mean, Lexi.”

“Yes, my lord,” the hell’s knight replied to his new liege immediately.

“Let’s start with getting rid of this wall. I’ve been enduring the aura it’s emanating with the help of the Asrahan Core Technique, but it’s still a little disturbing. You can remove this, right?”

“Of course, my lord.”

“Then do it.”

“As you command,” Sir Giolexius nodded.

Whoosh. The wall disappeared in an instant, like the fire on the gas burner ran out of fuel, and the cell phone screen turned off due to insufficient battery. The wall of magical energy that shrouded the entire city was gone, just like that, without requiring a complex incantation, evil ritual, or a special performance.

“Dude,” Lloyd tilted his head in confusion.

“I am at your service, my lord.”

“That’s it?”

“It’s a rather simple process, my lord.”

“Really?”

“Yes, my lord, because it’s more like turning off the wall instead of destroying it.”

“Then why didn’t you turn it off before?”

“Because you hadn’t asked, my lord.”

“Really.”

“I’m speaking the truth, my lord.”

“Are you sure you didn’t keep it on because having it on was more convenient for you?”

“...”

“I should have expected a hell’s knight, who’s best friends with Satan, to be a pathological liar!”

“I-I’m not lying, my lord!” Sir Giolexius vehemently denied.

“Are you serious?”

“Yes, my lord.”

“Then can you re-raise that magical wall any time you want?”

“No, my lord. It takes thorough preparations to actually erect it.”

“That’s a relief,” said Lloyd, gesturing at Javier and Sir Giolexius. “Let’s get going, then. We have a lot of work to do.”

He left the city hall with the two, and out of the city towards the temporary camp, in which citizens were outside of their tents despite the time of the night. Regardless of their status and wealth, pretty much everyone was murmuring and clamoring about what could have transpired.

To be fair, they just saw Namaran’s Wall being erected and disappearing in a short period of time.

Lloyd suspected the citizens found it strange and mesmerizing, yet mysterious and terrifying. The estate developer passed through the crowd unnoticed, thanks to the hooded robes all three of them were dressed in, and went into the countess’s tent.

“You’ve returned safely,” said Countess of Namaran, rising from her seat immediately to greet them, before flinching at the sight of the hell’s knight.

“It’s okay,” intervened Lloyd immediately, noticing the look on her face. “Our hell’s knight doesn’t bite... I mean, he won’t cause any trouble.”

“Won't cause any trouble?”

“Yes, my lady. He just signed an employment contract and agreed to work for me for the next five years.”

“...”

“You don’t have to stare at me like that, ahem. Anyhow, we got it taken care of. You saw the wall rise and disappear, correct?”

“I surely did. Please tell me none of you are hurt.”

“We are not, thanks to your prayers,” Lloyd replied with a huge smile on his face. “The wall is permanently taken care of, and nothing like this will occur again. It’s safe to allow the citizens to return to their homes. And I must get back to my estate immediately.”

“To Frontera Estate? Right now?”

“Yes, my lady. Forgive me for being unable to tell you the details,” said Lloyd with a bitter smile.

“Since you’re keen on returning without repairing the stabilization piles that support the cliff,” said Countess of Namaran, having read Lloyd’s intentions. “Something must have happened there that requires your immediate attention.”

“It’s going to very soon. But I would like to make this promise.”

“What kind of promise?”

“I will come back and make repairs to the structures after the issue back in my estate is resolved.”

“For free?”

“No way.”

“I should have expected.”

“That’s how things work in the world, after all.”

Lloyd smilingly assured the countess by telling her there are a few stabilization piles and anchors that were undamaged and solid, and that they wouldn’t collapse unless the cliff side sustains additional big damages. He was sorry to have to leave like this, but the city should be safe for the time being, and he was going to come back before anything else happened. He promised and gave her his word, shortly before departing from the camp to

hop on the back of Draggy, who began dancing happily upon seeing the hell's knight like a retriever wagging its tails at the sight of its owner.

"What the hell...?" Lloyd asked Sir Giolexius, who responded by shrugging his shoulders.

"It seems particularly happy to see me."

"You? Why? Do you know each other?"

"No."

"Then why?"

"Mm... I think it's telling us that he's no longer the newest member of the skeleton corp..."

"Aha."

Sir Lexi was the newest member of the corp, meaning his seniors were going to pick on him. Lloyd barely managed to contain himself from bursting out in laughter from the thought of the hell's knight running errands, as Javier asked him a question.

"Master Lloyd. There is something I'm concerned about."

"What is it?"

"Are we not going to apprehend the culprit behind Namaran's Wall this time?"

"Oh, that," replied Lloyd with a grin, noticing the look of curiosity in Javier's eyes. "There's no need. As a matter of fact, there is no culprit."

"Huh?"

"There is nobody behind this phenomenon."

“Then... why were the stabilization piles embedded with some kind of mana...?”

“Enforced fate phenomenon.”

“...”

Javier was speechless. Lloyd turned around to elaborate.

“The mana that had dissipated in the past came back together due to the enforced restoration of fate, to the spot I discovered the jewel of noctanium during the first wall.”

“Are you saying that mana accumulated in the stabilization pile that was installed near that very spot?”

“Exactly,” Lloyd nodded at Javier’s perfect summary. It was the information he had received through the ending spoiler, in which he was brutally murdered by the hell’s knight. “Mana won’t gather there again, nor will the wall re-rise, because he is alive.”

Lloyd pointed at the hell’s knight Sir Giolexius, who nodded in response.

“That’s correct. The wall’s purpose is to awaken and summon me. As long as I’m alive, it won’t happen again.”

“You heard him,” Lloyd shrugged his shoulders.

“I see. That makes sense,” Javier nodded slowly.

“Of course it does.”

That really was the case. The enforced fate phenomenon, in fact, would force certain events that were prevented to re-occur in a similar way in the same spot. But with the hell’s knight still alive, despite the new employment contract and all; that didn’t particularly alter the predestined fate.

Namaran's Wall's purpose is to gather enough mana in order to summon hell's knight Giolexius. The wall completely served its purpose, since he is still alive.

Lloyd suspected the wall wouldn't re-rise, as long as Giolexius worked for him. That was going to keep Namaran safe.

That's why I didn't kill him.

Keeping him alive and making him serve Lloyd instead was the ultimate goal the estate developer had in his mind.

Whew. Mission accomplished.

Lloyd breathed a deep sigh of relief. He wasn't confident he could get things done like this again. He was scared and afraid on one side, but optimistic on the other.

"First things first. Let's go back to the estate."

Whoosh! Draggy stomped on the ground and soared into the sky, taking Lloyd and others on its back away from Namaran. They flew all night and saw the sunrise, as they traveled through the morning mist of the mountain range and arrived in the estate. Lloyd immediately went to the mansion as soon as they landed, but not to see his parents.

"Hello? Are you there?"

Knock, knock. Lloyd knocked on the door of the guest rather softly, putting his ear on the door to see if he could hear anything. He couldn't.

He must be asleep.

But he couldn't even hear the sound of breathing, despite possessing the enhanced hearing ability of the swordmaster.

Dragon king Verkis. I knew he was the biggest bum in the world.

Lloyd wondered how deep one's sleep had to be, to make absolutely no noise. He suspected Verkis had reached a transcendental state in sleeping, as he cautiously turned the doorknob. The door wasn't locked, to his relief.

Good.

Lloyd slowly and silently pushed the door a little with the intent to head inside carefully, and gently wake the dragon king Verkis up. He was going to try his best not to agitate him, making offers he couldn't possibly refuse, so as to persuade him to fight for the estate.

If that works, the invasion by the hell's army is nothing to worry about. As powerful as they are, they're no match for the dragon king.

The dragon king could perhaps even give the king of hell a run for his money in a duel, based on the might he had displayed. Lloyd was hopeful, convinced, and desperate. He took a peek into the room with those thoughts in his heart, however, only to be flustered.

Huh?

He wasn't there. Verkis was nowhere to be seen in the entire guest chamber.

What? Did he use magic or something?

Lloyd wondered if the dragon king had cast the invisibility spell to conceal himself, in order to get even better sleep. The estate developer quickly operated all three circles with the help of the Asrahan Core Technique, thoroughly searching the flow of mana in the vicinity. It was no use.

He isn't here.

He couldn't detect a single breath, or a single streak of mana by Verkis. It was absolutely unexpected and frustrating.

Dragon king Verkis is the laziest bum I know. He can't have left his bed and gone elsewhere. This doesn't make any sense.

This was something Lloyd had never anticipated, unless there was a trigger. But Lloyd looked around and discovered a certain item that could hint at the possibility: a small note on the end table.

“...”

Lloyd picked up the note, which contained only a few words: *Gone. Don’t. Kill.*

“...”

Lloyd had initially thought this was some kind of a code that needed to be deciphered. However, it wasn’t.

Gone. Don’t. Kill. Could it mean I’m gone, don’t look for me, or I’ll kill you?

It appeared Verkis was too lazy to write down complete sentences, and that was convincing enough for Lloyd to believe it.

Okay, this is definitely left by Verkis. He left, and he’s threatening to kill me if I find him and bother him.

Lloyd let out a bitter chuckle at the realization.

Tsk. I could easily resolve this issue with the help of Verkis.

But this seemed out of the picture as of now. Knowing the dragon king, Lloyd thought he couldn’t depend on him.

He doesn’t listen to others, and is moody. The only person he ever listens to is his wife. He’s a selfish prick and acts on impulse. If someone like him went through the trouble to leave a note...

Lloyd couldn’t help but think that it was a strong expression of his will. Defying his will in a situation like this did not seem to be a good idea.

I’m going to die for real.

Dragon king sponsorship or not, Lloyd was going to infuriate him and be killed in an instant. He suspected he could die by the hands of the dragon king before facing the king of hell. Having calculated that much, Lloyd grinned bitterly and accepted it.

Alright, the dragon king's help is out of the picture.

Lloyd had just lost his biggest trump card, and that gave him a massive headache. But he wasn't going to give up just yet.

"Master Lloyd. What do we do now?"

"Hmm. I suppose we'll have to go with plan B."

"Plan B?"

"Yeah," Lloyd nodded at Javier and asked the frowning knight in an assuring manner. "Have you ever showered in two billion liters of holy water?"

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Chapter 381: Touch the Angel's Heart (1)

"Have you ever showered in two billion tons of holy water?"

Flinch! The hell's knight Sir Giolexius shuddered at Lloyd's casual mentioning of "two billion liters of holy water," while Javier frowned his picturesquely beautiful eyebrows instead.

"Holy water?" Javier asked.

"Do you not know what it is?"

"I do, obviously."

"Of course."

"Yeah," Javier nodded, proceeding to explain the obvious. "I heard it's a sacred liquid produced through desperate prayers of high-ranking priests, and that it's extremely effective on the likes of apparitions, evil spirits, demons, and other undeads."

"You're right. It's indeed extremely effective."

Lloyd nodded. As a matter of fact, the holy water could permanently destroy ordinary ghouls and zombies with a single drop or two, and even weaken a powerful demon to the level of a common human by splashing the liquid.

"The hell's knight would also sustain huge damage from the holy water. I suspect he wouldn't be able to put up a decent fight for a while."

"Probably. A regular swordmaster should be able to give him a challenge."

"That's where I'm going with this."

Lloyd chuckled satisfactorily, but Javier wasn't too convinced.

"But that scenario sounds way too plausible. It's unrealistic."

“Unrealistic?”

“Yeah.”

“Do you think it’s farfetched?”

“A little bit.”

“Why?”

“Because you said two billion liters.”

“I certainly did.”

“That’s exactly why,” said Javier, frowning his gorgeous eyebrows again to elaborate with a sharp tongue. “Is it even possible to gather that much holy water? As far as I know, it takes an extremely devoted high-ranking priest’s continuous effort, involving non-stop fasting and prayer, for 100 days to fill a small ink bottle with the holy water.”

“That’s true. You’re absolutely correct.”

“Two billion liters is just outrageous.”

“But it isn’t.”

“How so?”

“Because I’m going to get my hands on the holy water extract, not the finished product itself,” Lloyd’s smile became more prominent as he continued explaining to Javier. “Raphael, the angel of thrones.”

“...Ah,” paused Javier, causing Lloyd’s smile to get even greater.

“Do you finally get it?”

“Are you planning to obtain the angel’s tears?”

“Obviously,” Lloyd nodded confidently, as that was certainly possible and would give him a fine advantage. “You know what the angel’s tears are capable of, correct?”

“Yeah. I had heard about it from a passing pilgrim that happened to stop by the village I grew up in, when I was little.”

“That’s when you heard it?”

“Yeah. I heard the angel’s tears are key ingredients in producing the holy water.”

“Precisely. One drop of angel’s tear is enough to fill a good number of bottles.”

“But two billion liters is still too... farfetched.”

“How?”

“Because one drop of angel’s tear is enough to make about one liter of holy water, from what I had heard when I was a child. Am I mistaken?”

Javier tilted his head in confusion. Lloyd’s claim to produce two billion liters of holy water, and the confidence with which the estate developer made such statements, made absolutely no sense to the grandmaster.

“You learned it right. To get into more details, one milliliter of angel’s teardrop mixed with one liter of pure water equals one liter of holy water.”

Lloyd grinned mysteriously. It was true. Holy water was produced at the ratio of one part angel’s teardrop to one thousand parts pure water.

The ratio is a bit different, but it’s like mixing bleach with water.

It wasn’t too far from making a solution of bleach and water before starting to mop the floors. Creating the holy water the same way from angelic teardrops and water in a specific ratio was going to produce a fine solution to get rid of zombies, ghouls, apparitions, demons, etc. like germs and mold in between the tiles.

“Except, that ratio only applies with the teardrop of tier-9 angels, which are the lowest in rank,” added Lloyd.

“Wait a minute. Does that mean the teardrop of higher ranking angels is...?”

“Exactly,” Lloyd nodded, as he proceeded to explain with a subtle look of superiority on his face. “The effectiveness of the teardrop increases by ten times with each rank.”

“That means...”

“Right. 1 milliliter of a tier-8 angel’s tears is enough to produce 10 liters of holy water, and that of a tier-7 angel, 100 liters. It’s simple math. How many liters of holy water, then could 1 milliliter of tears from a tier-3 angel of thrones?”

“...”

“Come on, it’s simple math.”

“...”

“Are you seriously still counting?”

“No. I was done with the math a while ago. It’s just that...”

“I’m listening.”

“It’s still one million liters.”

“Well done,” said Lloyd, with the look of a tutor giving the tutee some math lessons. “You’re right. Theoretically, one milliliter of tears from the angel of thrones is enough to produce one million liters of holy water.”

“...”

“Ten milliliters would become ten million liters of holy water, 100 milliliters 100 million, and one liter one billion.”

“...”

“Basically, two liters of tears from the angel of thrones is all we need.”

“...”

“Dude.”

“...”

“Why aren’t you saying anything?”

“Well,” Javier finally broke the silence, frowning further. “I was concerned before because of how unrealistic the plan sounded in the beginning.”

“And?”

“But now, I’m genuinely concerned about Raphael.”

“Why?”

“Because you would certainly and easily extract two liters of tears from anybody, let alone from an angel.”

“You’re making me look like a ruthless cutthroat exploiting people around me.”

“...”

“Is that what you were really thinking?”

Javier silently but genuinely nodded. Lloyd snorted at the inability to refute the idea and tried to change the subject quickly.

“Anyhow, that’s the plan. Two liters of tears from the angel of thrones. How does that sound?”

That could produce two billion liters of holy water, which was enough to make the entire hell’s corp enjoy a wave pool in a water park, let alone

shower them.

I've also taken into account how to gather that much pure water to go with it, manufacture the holy water, and spray it at the enemies.

It was all-inclusive in the alternate plan. Lloyd went over the plan once again, as Javier shrugged his shoulders on the side.

"If it's theoretically possible, it's certainly worth a try."

"See? What do you think, Lexi?"

"...I'm afraid."

"Huh? What is?"

Hell's knight Sir Giolexius appeared intimidated, unlike Javier.

"Two billion liters of holy water? It's sending chills down my spine just to hear it. You don't plan to splash me with that, do you?"

"Of course not. But let me ask you something. What would happen if you were to get submerged under the holy water?"

"It is similar to what you have said before. I would become as fragile as a swordmaster."

"For how long?"

"I think I would need at least an hour for me to be freed from the lingering effect of the holy water and regain my strength."

"Hmm. Perfect."

"But I'm afraid there is one problem, my lord."

"Problem?"

“The plan you just explained to Sir Javier is excellent. You carefully devised the method to produce the holy water, and would certainly end up with an abundance of it should it succeed. However, wouldn’t your method require the help of a high-ranking angel...?”

“You’re right.”

“That’s what concerns me, my lord. You are a human, and I can’t see how you can possibly enlist the help of a heavenly being.”

“Aha. You’re afraid I may have trouble causing the angel to descend from heaven because I’m not a high-ranking priest or anything.”

“That’s correct, my lord. But it is a task you must accomplish for your plan to work,” Sir Giolexius replied with a serious glow in his eyes.

“Task. That won’t be a problem,” said Lloyd, placing his hand over his chin.

“Huh?”

“I’m a master of accomplishing tasks I am given.”

Lloyd smilingly grinned. In fact, Lloyd had never failed an assigned task when he was in school. Regardless of how difficult the assignment was, or how tired he was, he had always completed all tasks he was given.

I worked my butt off during the deferment period to earn tuition. I wasn’t going to lose a single point from my GPA from the lack of effort.

Suho couldn’t afford to get complacent. He had to get things done desperately. Lloyd was reminded of that time of endless endeavor and smiled.

“I think that task has been completed.”

“Huh?”

The hell’s knight couldn’t understand what Lloyd meant by it. The estate developer noticed the look on his face and pointed behind Sir Giolexius with his chin.

“Look behind you. I think he’s overheard our conversation. It may be an unexpected encounter for you, but there he is.”

“...What?”

The hell’s knight was astonished by the presence of someone he had least expected from behind him and shook his entire body.

“A-angel of thrones!”

Angel of Thrones Raphael responded to the hell’s knight’s shout of surprise. However, the reply wasn’t that nerve-wracking tension or blatant hostility by any means. The angel of thrones and the hell’s knight greeted each other by shaking hands.

“Oh? Commander of hell’s first corp! It’s great to see you!”

“Likewise. How long has it been? Is it our first meeting since the Divine-Demon War?”

“I think so. How is your mother doing?”

“She passed away 3,761 years ago.”

“Oh, no. I’m so sorry.”

“But she died of old age. She didn’t particularly have a tough time.”

“I see. I was so occupied with work that I couldn’t even come by. My deepest condolences.”

“No need. We are both bound by duties, which we must prioritize.”

“True enough. That’s why we had to cross blades with each other during the war.”

“We did, although I was starting to have an advantage.”

“Was that so? Because I remember I was slightly on the better side.”

“Tsk, tsk. Angels these days. You have terrible memories.”

“Hahaha, not as bad as you, commander.”

“Oh? We can always settle it in a duel here.”

“Not now. I’m only a guest in this estate.”

“What?”

“I only happened to run across you because I was spending some time here. Isn’t that right?”

Raphael put a smile on his face and turned to Lloyd, who responded with a bitter smile of his own instead of a certain thought in his mind.

I knew it. It’s exactly as The Knight of Blood and Iron said. Good thing I decided to bring the hell’s knight to my estate.

Lloyd was reminded of the relationship between citizens of the heavenly realm and those of the underworld, as per the original novel.

The divine realm and the underworld don’t necessarily oppose one another, although there have been a few altercations between them such as the Divine-Demon War. But that was an extremely special case.

In reality, they weren’t enemies. They were more like different divisions of a large corporation.

They manage different realms under the same god, like administrators and managers of different departments in a big company.

To put it simply, the heavenly realm was like the administrative department that took care of the day-to-day operation of the world, including but not limited to addressing customer and client complaints in the form of prayers,

the underworld was a special department that specialized in post-business duties in the form of punishment and reincarnation of the soul after the death of the physical body.

They have trouble with one another because of the discrepancy in their work, not because they harbor personal grudges against each other, just like how different departments of the company prioritize different goals.

Because this was the case, some angels and hell's knights were actually great friends despite the divisions they were in, against the common misconception.

This is also why I can't expect the heavenly realm's help in the invasion by the hell's army. They don't particularly oppose each other, and the heavenly realm may not care, or even actually want the predestined fate to be restored.

That was why Lloyd did not request reinforcements from the heavenly realm, despite having failed to procure dragon king Verkis's help. He knew it wasn't going to be meaningless.

"Anyhow, since you seem to know each other already, I suppose I don't need to introduce Lexi to you."

"Lexi? Are you referring to the nickname of the first corp commander?"

"Yeah. He agreed to work with me under a contract for five years."

"I see," Raphael replied with a flustered look in his eyes, shortly before turning into that of compassion towards Sir Giolexius. It was full of pity towards the hell's knight for having signed a contract with someone like Lloyd. "First corp commander. Have you by any chance... heard the song?"

"Wait. Have you...?"

The two looked at each other pitifully and compassionately, causing Lloyd to stare at them uncomfortably.

“Forget the songs. But it’s good to see you here because there was something I needed to ask.”

“Ask? Me?”

“Yeah.”

“Well, let’s hear it.”

The angel of thrones was no stranger to Lloyd’s evil genius; he cautiously asked Lloyd what he had in his mind. Lloyd, however, did not care one bit about Raphael’s stance and proceeded with the plan anyway.

“If, by any chance, I were to pluck out your armpit hair while listening to my beautiful, heart-touching songs again, would that cause you to shed tears at all?”

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Chapter 382: Touch the Angel's Heart (2)

"If, by any chance, I were to pluck out your armpit hair while listening to my beautiful, heart-touching songs again, would that cause you to shed tears at all?"

Raphael became speechless at the shamelessly outrageous question asked by Lloyd. The Angel of Thrones took a moment of silence to reply.

"My apologies. I don't have any armpit hair."

"Hmm."

"I'm serious," the angel insisted.

"What about other parts of the body?"

"I might."

"Whew. That's a relief."

The angel was flustered by Lloyd's response as he hadn't given him permission at all but tried to contain his feelings and replied.

"No. I don't think that would work."

"Why not?"

"Because I wouldn't shed tears that way."

"Hmm. Are you making a statement about your endurance?"

"No," said the Angel of Thrones, shaking his head. "I do not shed tears from the physical pain. It has nothing to do with my patience. All angels are like that."

"Hmm..."

“I’m telling the truth.”

“Hmm...”

“I am being honest.”

“Hmm...”

“I’m not lying. Look at the flaming halo. It’s still burning well.”

“Hmm...”

Lloyd began staring at the Angel of Thrones scrupulously as if he was trying to pick out the freshest fish at the seafood stall. The look of persistence suggested he was attempting to figure out if the angel was indeed being truthful.

What is up with him...?

The Angel of Thrones genuinely wondered. The tears of angels were highly valuable, and those of a high-ranking angel such as himself were even more priceless.

Lloyd Frontera loves money, perhaps even excessively. Is he trying to...?

The angel wondered if Lloyd was planning to sell his tears by any chance. Raphael’s face turned solemn at such thoughts as he asked.

“Are you in need of my tears?”

“Yeah. That’s why I’m asking.”

“Why do you need them?”

“So that we may all survive together.”

“...What?”

The Angel of Thrones was astonished by the unexpected answer that emphasized surviving together. Lloyd added.

“I’ll be brief and to the point. A certain undead sorcerer, who has now become a lich, requested the king of hell to open the hell’s gate in this estate to deploy the hell’s army here. The king of hell accepted the plea, and evil soldiers would storm this place very soon. All of us will die and this estate will be razed to ashes. Not a single soul will live.”

“Are you serious?” Raphael responded with a troubled look on his face.

“It’s true,” Sir Giolexius intervened and replied in Lloyd’s stead.

Raphael did not know what to say to this. Sir Giolexius was the commander of the first corp of hell’s army until only a few moments ago, so there was not a shred of a doubt that it really was the case.

“Then, were you trying to secure my tears to fend them off?”

“That is precisely it,” Lloyd replied with a nod.

“I would love to help out if that’s the case,” said the Angel of Thrones, frustratingly biting his lips. “But there still is a problem.”

“Problem?”

“I am unable to shed tears willingly,” continued Raphael. “I cannot shed tears even if I want to unless I am genuinely touched in my heart. As a matter of fact, all angels were created that way to prevent the abuse of our valuable tears.”

“Hmm. That’s why I was suggesting to pluck your armpit hair, to make it real.”

“If I can indeed shed tears from the physical pain of plucking my hair, and those tears could save the innocent and kind citizens of the estate, I would voluntarily pluck them all to protect the people. Unfortunately, however, that method won’t work. We angels do not cry from physical pain.”

“Is that so?”

“It is so. We must be genuinely moved in response to something touching. That’s the only way angels would shed tears.”

Raphael adamantly nodded, causing Lloyd to frowningly massage the back of his neck.

“That makes it a bit... challenging.”

“I agree. I would love to shed tears left and right, knowing they’re going to be used for the right cause.”

“Hmm. I think our best bet here is to try different methods, then.”

“I’m sorry?”

“This happened years ago in the distant past. There lived two brothers, one of which was wealthy and the other poor.”

“Huh...?” The Angel of Thrones frowned with one eyebrow as Lloyd continued in a serious tone.

“The younger brother was penniless because he had failed to live according to a constructive financial plan. He had more children than his salary could afford, and he would spend the hard-earned money unwisely without taking care of his family first, failing to save anything up.”

“Hmm, go on.”

“On the other hand, the older brother had amassed a great wealth. He was diligent, hard-working, and made smart investments by carefully studying risks and returns. And one day, the younger brother found a terribly injured swallow on the street by chance. Something moved him and he took the poor bird to his home, tended to its wounds, and let it go. The swallow returned with a seed of a sort, which the younger brother sowed. It grew into some kind of a plant, bearing a huge fruit that looked like a melon. When he opened the melon, it was actually full of valuables and treasure!”

“Interesting. What happened next?”

“The older brother was astounded by the single investment that yielded so much profit and turned his brother’s life upside down. He found himself an injured swallow... blah, blah... and opened the melon... blah, blah... but unfortunately lost all of his wealth.”

“Tsk, tsk. What a tragedy. What next?”

“The older brother, who was a competent and diligent entrepreneur, lost all of his wealth in an instant. The younger brother, who had spent his life without a well-laid-out plan, became rich instead. The older brother began living in the younger brother’s basement because he couldn’t afford rent. Later on, the younger brother gave half of his wealth to his older brother.”

“That’s actually a kind thing to do. What a beautiful story.”

“No, it’s actually a tragedy,” Lloyd interrupted the angel, immediately before Raphael lifted his hands to clap. “The older brother, who had worked hard all his life according to a solid business plan, lost all of his wealth due to one poor investment that enticed him with the promise of even greater riches. His younger brother gave him half of what he possessed later on, but that couldn’t have been for free.”

“Th-then...?”

“The younger brother probably made the older brother his personal asset manager or something, overworking and abusing him for the rest of their lives in return. Tsk, tsk. Poor older brother probably worked his butt off trying to make ends meet despite the terrible spending habit of the younger brother, and died without a chance to go on vacation.”

“...”

“What a tragic tale.”

Lloyd had drops of tears in his eyes, but the Angel of Thrones could only stare in silence. Lloyd noticed the look and added.

“I suppose no tragic tales are going to genuinely touch your heart. We’ll have to resort to a different method.”

“What method?”

“Are you ticklish on the bottom of your feet by any chance?” Lloyd took a glance at the angel’s feet.

“What do you plan to do with my feet?” The angel asked in a slightly uncomfortable voice.

“I mean to tickle you over there. Perhaps you would shed a little bit of tears if I continued tickling you despite your plea to make it stop.”

“Hmm. I don’t know if that’s going to work.”

“Let’s give it a try.”

Lloyd tried all sorts of methods he could think of, starting with this one, to make the Angel of Thrones shed tears. The tickling of his feet with a feather failed to make him cry. Lloyd found a pile of hot chili peppers in the kitchen storage, and brought a shovel-full of them and fed them to Angel of Thrones, but that also failed. He even sang a song with gorgeous melody to the angel’s ears while asking Javier to hold him down, but Raphael did not shed a single drop of tear.

It did not matter how hard Lloyd tickled him, how much spicy food he fed him, or how many times he raided the angel’s eardrums with terrible singing. The Angel of Thrones was definitely uncomfortable and agonized, but he did not shed tears. Lloyd was frustrated.

Tsk. This is bad.

Lloyd was in desperate need of the angel’s teardrops, because the battle against the hell’s army was going to be much more arduous without them. But he hadn’t anticipated the acquisition to be this difficult. The estate developer let out a deep sigh and spoke.

“Whoa. You really don’t shed tears.”

“I am so sorry. It really isn’t something I can control.”

“No need to apologize. But I won’t lie, I was hoping to make you cry like a cookie.”

“Huh? Why would the cookie cry?”

“Well,” Lloyd casually replied, with the intent to lighten the mood with a terrible joke. “Because his father was a wafer so long.”

“Because his father was a wafer... Oh! Away for so long?! Ha.”

“Huh?”

“Ha, ha. His father was a wafer... away for... I get it. Ahahaha.”

The Angel of Thrones placed his hands over the mouth to stop himself from bursting out in laughter. Lloyd noticed his shoulders violently twitch and his face and ears turn red.

What?!

The estate developer was certainly astounded by the unexpected response. This gave him an idea.

Please don’t tell me you’re terribly weak against dad jokes.

But Lloyd had nothing to lose, so he decided to give it a try anyways. He cleared his throat and turned towards the Angel of Thrones, who was struggling to hold his laughter in.

“I want you to cause a crisis today.”

“C-cause a c-crisis? What do you mean?”

“Because that would turn you into a woman that cries a lot. Cry-sis.”

“C-cry-sis! Ahahahaha! Oh, my goodness! Ahahahahaha!”

The Angel of Thrones held his abdomen as he started rolling on the ground. Lloyd genuinely questioned his common senses.

“...”

But all was well that ended well. His efforts were paying off.

Good, he’s genuinely laughing his butt off!

Lloyd sharply examined the eyes of the angel, who was struggling to hold it in. He saw a single drop of tear in his eyes.

Alright! Here comes another one!

It was a perfect opportunity to seal the win with another move. Lloyd threw in another one from his dad joke arsenal.

“You know, I went to the downtown the other day and saw a fat psychic. He introduced himself as a *four-chin teller.*”

“...Ahahahahahahahaha!!”

“And did you hear about the terrible fire at the shoe store? Many *soles* were lost.”

“...Ahahaha!!”

“What do you call a fish with no eyes? Fsh.”

“Ahahahaha, holy! Ahahahaha!”

“I got another joke about the roof... But it’s way over your head.”

“Ahahaha, please...! Stop!”

The Angel of Thrones was rolling around on the floor. Lloyd quickly gestured to Javier, who promptly responded by grabbing the cup on the table inside the guest room. The grandmaster knight carefully approached

the angel, who was still struggling to breathe from all the laughter and wiped his eyes. There was a teardrop on Javier's finger.

Quickly! Gather them in the cup!

Lloyd rolled his eyes to hint at what Javier needed to do. The grandmaster immediately gathered the tears in the cup as Lloyd continued spewing out terrible dad jokes, causing the angel to lose it completely. Raphael's abdomen and cheek muscles were straining from it, as he had a hard time breathing. And Javier continued taking every single drop of the tears the angel shed in a cup, without wasting any while giving Lloyd dirty looks for the horrendous jokes. Lloyd fully agreed with Javier on this one.

Gosh. I hate this too.

Lloyd breathed a heavy sigh at himself, for knowing so many dad jokes in the first place, and because he had to bombard the angel to get what he needed. It was embarrassing to the point where he wanted to run to his bedroom and hide under the blanket from the shame. It reminded him of a time when he was in college.

One of the professors used to throw in terrible dad jokes all the time during lectures.

Lloyd despised the professor's effort to appear humorous and had only chuckled bitterly. Perhaps that was why he felt guilty towards that particular instructor.

I am so sorry, professor. I didn't expect the dad jokes, out of all the things you taught me in class, to come in handy in a situation like this. Ugh.

He was grateful and shameful at the same time. However, Lloyd wasn't one to give up on his goals just because he had to endure some cringeworthy circumstances. He was determined to take one for the team, to ultimately accomplish his objectives. And the poetry of dad jokes somehow touched the angel's heart, filling a third of the cup in the process.

Nice. I think this is about a tenth of a liter.

The golden tears splashed inside the cup, as the Angel of Thrones nearly fainted on the floor from the laughter. Lloyd put up a huge smile on his face.

If I do this every day for about 20 days or so, I should be able to get enough tears for my plan to work.

Two whole liters of Raphael's tears could be used as ingredients to produce 2 billion liters of holy water.

"Alright, it looks like we got our work cut out for us," Lloyd glanced at Javier.

The grandmaster's face, however, was distressed from the bombardment of terrible dad jokes. Lloyd also noticed that the hell's knight had plugged his ears to avoid hearing anything. Lloyd put up an evil grin and added.

"Do you not like the idea?"

"No. I hate it," Javier replied, twitching his body like he had just seen something disgusting. But there was an element of sharpness in what he said afterward. "But since you're collecting tears this way."

"I'm listening."

"I have concerns about actually turning this into the holy water, even if we do succeed in gathering two whole liters like this."

"What concerns?"

"We need two billion liters of pure water on top of that. Where are you going to procure that much water? And how do you plan to spray these to the hell's army during battle?"

Javier addressed his honest concerns without being sarcastic. Procuring and managing two billion liters of pure water was especially what worried him.

"Oh, that."

But Lloyd responded so casually like he already laid out a careful plan, step by step in detail, as he had always done. And Lloyd's solution that followed appalled Javier.

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Chapter 383: Honest Thoughts (1)

“Lake Kapua. We’ll produce holy water there.”

“Huh?” Javier frowned at the mention of Lake Kapua in Lloyd’s response to his concerns about where to procure 2 billion liters of pure water and how to apply the holy water to the demonic army. “Are you saying Lake Kapua holds that much water?”

“Approximately. I think there’s about 1.9 to two billion liters,” Lloyd shrugged his shoulders.

Lake Kapua, sitting in the middle of the mountain range east of the Frontera Estate, was a huge lake that was created artificially due to the dam-building activity by Bibeong. Its size was astounding.

It’s humongous in terms of width and depth, almost as big as the largest reservoir in South Korea, although Lake Kapua is a bit shallower. But it definitely holds enough water to produce two billion liters of holy water.

According to Lloyd’s calculations, the full volume of water Lake Kapua held was about two billion tons. He suspected he could get approximately two billion liters of freshwater by creating sections near the intake station in the western part of the lake, which was perfect for creating the desired amount of holy water.

“To tell you the truth, I went with two billion liters of holy water in the first place considering the volume of water Lake Kapua held.”

“Oh, really?”

“Yeah.”

“But I do have another concern.”

“Shoot it.”

“You’re not planning to turn the lake into holy water, are you?”

“I am.”

“...”

“Not the entirety of the lake, perhaps. But a whole section of it for sure.”

“...”

“We wouldn’t need to worry about storage that way.”

“But what about the water that gets supplied to the waterworks and dyeworks in Lacona Barony?”

“That wouldn’t matter. Releasing a little bit into the waterworks won’t affect the total volume of two billion liters at all.”

“That’s not what I’m worried about. I was concerned about the citizens having to use holy water in their everyday lives instead.”

“Holy water from waterworks. That actually sounds amazing.”

“...”

“Citizens will get healthier by drinking it, and the dye color will become more vibrant and gorgeous. But I am kinda curious.”

“About what?”

“If you drink the holy water and pee... is that a holy pee?”

“...”

“I’m sorry.”

“So you do know that was lame.”

“Yeah. Anyways,” said Lloyd with a smile of huge confidence, as if he had everything planned out carefully, and all preparations were set in place. “We will convert a good chunk of the reservoir into holy water, and I have already thought of the way to effectively apply that to the enemies, although we got some work to do to make that possible. But you may rest assured.”

“Understood.”

“...Huh?”

“Huh?” Javier replied with the same response.

“Are you alright...?”

“I am. What’s wrong?”

“That was an unexpected response,” Lloyd tilted his head in confusion. “Understood? That’s not the kind of response I expected from you. You would have talked back with thousands of other questions.”

“...”

“Please don’t tell me you’re someone else in Javier’s body.”

“I am Javier.”

“Then why...?”

“Are you dissatisfied with my agreement?”

“No. I just find it unfamiliar.”

“You’ll have to get used to it,” Javier replied with a chuckle.

He meant it. Javier had decided to trust whatever Lloyd was going to say from here on. But the grandmaster did not express his honest thoughts to his master and pretended otherwise.

“Agreeing with you from time to time will loosen you up, and that’s when I’ll strike with the sharpest questions to catch you off guard.”

“Seriously?”

“Seriously.”

“Ugh. You devil.”

“You’re one to speak.”

“If I do it, it’s okay. But not you.”

“That’s not fair. You mustn’t be so shameless about speaking such nonsense.”

“What’s there to life?” Lloyd asked with a bitter chuckle. “If I don’t have anything of substance, I should at least display composure outwardly.”

Lloyd hadn’t thought much about this statement when he spoke it, but realized it actually was an accurate representation of how he had lived his life. The estate developer quickly attempted to retract the smile before it got even bitterer.

“Anyhow. We have our work cut out for us, but not today. I need to do my part as a good person today.”

“What do you mean by that?”

“I need to see my parents and tell them I came back.”

But the smile got bitter nonetheless. It felt as though Count Frontera and his wife were his real parents. Lloyd shook his head violently to brush this thought aside.

What the hell am I thinking? I’m actually a scoundrel that took over the body of their real son. In a way, I have committed a grave sin against them. I must not take this for granted and act like I deserve this.

Lloyd wondered if he had grown to love them as his real family, but suppressed this feeling that he felt he did not deserve. Even if the count and the countess were to embrace him as their own, Lloyd convinced himself that he shouldn't expect any kind of familial love from them, until he was accepted by them despite having explained the truth about the real Lloyd. He constantly reminded himself of this as he approached where the count and the countess were, and said his greetings.

"I am back."

"...Huh?"

The two had been exchanging words over a finely brewed cup of tea after a meal when the count and the countess both got up immediately from their seats and rushed to Lloyd with a look of pleasant surprise on their faces.

"You're back."

They held Lloyd by his hands and took a good look all over his body from head to toe, before proceeding to make eye contact with him with the warm look that suggested so many different things, all of which Lloyd felt in his heart.

They had been concerned about what trouble Lloyd was going through, his health, if he was eating properly on time, and ultimately, if he was alright. The lack of actual words perhaps made it even more empathetic, inadvertently making Lloyd drop his guard despite the constant reminder he had been telling himself on his way. Lloyd replied with a huge smile like he would have done against his real parents.

"Yeah. I'm back."

No other words were necessary, as the count and the countess welcomed Lloyd back with open arms. They proudly tapped him on his shoulders and felt his calloused hands, as they just smiled silently, yet telling him that he had done enough already.

The count and the countess thought to themselves, that even though the Lloyd in front of them wasn't their real son, and they didn't know why and how this all happened, the man in their presence was virtually no different from their own now. He was a good and hard-working kid, and he was going to tell them everything in due time. They were determined not to treat him differently from their real children and thereby hurt him in the process. That was the last thing they wanted. With this virtuous intent, they greeted Lloyd with a genuine smile and warmth, displaying parental concerns throughout the encounter. That was why Lloyd had no idea what the count and the countess were thinking and still believed they did not know about his secrets. He appreciated them, yet harbored guilt on one side. This made him strengthen his resolve once more to protect them like his real parents from any harm or hardships that came their way.

That night, when everyone had gone to sleep, Lloyd used the ending spoiler once again to see how the battle against the hell's army was going to go.

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"...Huff. Huff. Huff."

He ran. He stomped on the ground and jumped over dead bodies to continue, running out of breath on his way.

"Huff, huff! The hell's army... will invade... 90 days later!"

Slash! One demon fell from the strike. He jumped over the freshly deceased corpse and stretched out his shovel shrouded in the swordmaster's aura, clashing against a greatsword.

Clink! The greatsword stopped the shovel from advancing further, as deadly glows stared at him from behind the weapon. A hell's knight parried the shovel effortlessly and pushed it aside.

Krakakaka! The shovel slid down the blade as the greatsword moved masterfully to threaten the man, who ducked quickly to barely dodge the attack.

Kwoosh! The gust from its swing swept through the man’s hair, sending chills down his spine. But he did not have time to think about that, as another presence full of hostility was rushing towards him from his back.

“...Urgh! The size of the enemy’s army... is about...”

He jumped up from a crouched position like a spring and took a step sideways, swinging his shovel.

Clank!

He had barely managed to block the greatsword attack that came from behind. But it was more like a baseball being hit by a bat.

“...Ack!”

The man lost balance and rolled on the ground. He had let go of the shovel from the loss of strength in his hands, but he quickly lifted his chin without trying to figure out what was going on.

The other hell’s knight that had struck him from behind was now standing right in front of him, glaring at him through eyes that burned like fire. The man’s heart began to heat up as if a piece of steel that had just been through the furnace was applied.

Kwoosh. The sound wasn’t particularly loud. In fact, it was so subtle that it almost made him chuckle. He couldn’t believe such a puny sound came from the puncturing of a human body.

Pierce. Pierce.

It hurt. The stabbing and slashing came from all directions. The dark blades pierced through flesh and blood with the intent to end a life.

The man felt excruciating pain each time an organ was punctured and twitched violently. But he couldn’t scream in agony. Instead, he could only let out a feeble sound similar to a deflating balloon. His vision blurred as the reddened sky swirled. The man wondered if tears were obstructing his view. But they seemed rather dark for teardrops.

“...Ugh. Agh...”

The man wanted to speak. He had to say something. But he was quickly losing himself. He felt his soul drift away as a profuse amount of blood left his body, amidst the spooky cries and surreal pain keeping him in absolute fear. But the voices of the hell’s knights that slashed and pierced him were so clear despite all that.

“You who will become a new vassal of our liege.”

“We welcome you, Lloyd Frontera.”

“And congratulate you.”

“Suho Kim. You will now be working with us.”

“Ugh... Agh...”

The man desperately wished to refute the statement, but he couldn’t speak. His vision continued to blur even further, and he could only see the bluish glow in the eyes of the hell’s knight that approached him with the intent to swallow him alive. The nefarious light was about to gouge his eyes out before taking him into the abyss. It got closer. It drove him mad. It was killing him. It was destroying him.

“...Aaaaaack!”

Lloyd got up from the bed, shaking in fear. His toes have rolled up from the tension, as he held tightly onto the blanket over his body covered in cold sweat. He then took a glance at his chest, still breathing hard.

“Huff... Huff... Huh?”

There was nothing. There was no greatsword, no punctured organs, or blood. It indicated one thing.

“Th-that was all a dream...? Ha. Haha.”

But he still felt the chills down his spine, and his pillow was soaked in tears. Lloyd let out a huge sigh of relief only after confirming he was still alone in his dark, quiet bedroom.

“Haha. Holy. What kind of nightmare...”

It was a fearsome dream and a chillingly realistic one too. It had to feel that way.

“To dream about what I saw in the ending spoiler... Phew.”

The nightmare that had just wakened Lloyd up was, in fact, what he checked through the ending spoiler before he went to sleep. He trembled violently again at the thought.

Gosh. And I had trouble falling asleep because I was so troubled by it.

It involved the most tragic way of death he had ever seen. Lloyd had shuddered just at the thought of how realistic the dream was, and couldn’t go back to sleep. His heart was too deeply in trouble, despite knowing in his head that he had to get as much rest as he could to start working on preparations to save the estate from the invading army. He had constantly reminded himself that sleeping for the time being was the best thing to do given the situation, and finally fell asleep albeit barely.

Tsk, tsk. And I only slept for a good thirty minutes at best.

Lloyd took a peek out the window and concluded based on the darkness of the night. He picked up a cup of water he had placed on the end table, and chugged it down to satiate his thirst. He was wide awake.

Jeez. I don’t think I can go back to sleep tonight.

Since it appeared that way, Lloyd decided to review what he saw in the ending spoiler before he went to bed.

I was surrounded by hell’s knight when I died. Let’s see... I think there were about five hell’s knights attacking me.

Lloyd happened to take a glance at the estate, that had become a battlefield on which hell's knights were wreaking havoc. The legion of White Cavalry was being overpowered while the dragon Solitas and Draggy were struggling to hold their own. Even Javier, the grandmaster, was having a rough time against more than ten hell's knights focusing on taking him down. Lloyd was confident he counted more than 200 hell's knights in the process.

200 at least. I can't help but suspect the actual number is greater.

He wondered what happened to the two billion liters of holy water, and if he failed to utilize it in the predetermined future.

Or it could still not be enough. That is most likely. The method I am thinking of currently is probably not sufficient enough to weaken the hell's army adequately. I need to think this over and come up with a better plan. The only consolation is that they'll be invading 90 days later. I must devise a better tactic, find more reinforcements, and do whatever it takes to stop them. It will be tough, but I think I can change the ending. I will. I must.

Lloyd began taking more things into account as he filled the cup with water and drank twice more. But his hands shook the entire time, causing him to struggle. The shaking extended into his eyes, indicating he was clearly in shock.

"Damn it. What the hell."

Lloyd found it mysterious as to why he was still shivering and sweating like a terrified child. He kept reminding himself that it was only a dream and that there was no reason for him to shudder like this. But he couldn't. He did not understand why.

"I don't want to die..."

Without realizing it, he began to shed tears. Lloyd cried out silently in fear. He was scared, and he did not want to die. He did not want others to get involved in this mess because of him. The responsibility he had to bear was

so great, that Lloyd sobbed quietly for some time all alone in his private bedroom.

Lloyd had no idea, due to the overflowing emotions he felt, that Javier was standing outside in the hallway the entire night without a word. The grandmaster was unable to open the door and was just strengthening his resolve all by himself.

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Chapter 384: Honest Thoughts (2)

It hurt. Every time that man put up a blatantly false front and tried to bear the burdens all alone, it shook and broke Javier's heart.

Fake Lloyd. Why would you...

Javier let out a subtle sigh and leaned on the wall out in the hallway, silently staring at the tightly closed door to the bedroom across which he could hear small sounds of sobbing. It was that of fake Lloyd Frontera shedding tears without making noises. The usual, shameless composure of the man was gone as he cried like a completely different person. He was only showing his true self when no one else was around him.

He really said he didn't want to die.

Javier inadvertently clenched his fist as he was reminded of Lloyd's statement in agony. He didn't understand why, but it was infuriating for some reason.

Why would you want to bear the burdens all by yourself? Just why?

Javier genuinely wondered. He wasn't the true son of House Frontera. He was only wearing the shell of Lloyd. He had all the excuses to take a step back to avoid certain crises, but he instead always faced the difficulties head-on with more responsibility than the real Lloyd ever showed. He risked his own life each time to solve the issue and would shed tears privately.

Why can't you just tell me that you're having a tough time? Why can't you admit that you're afraid?

But Javier knew Lloyd wouldn't. He wasn't like that. He would always put up a front and act like he was the most poised person in the world.

Come to think of it, he's always shown it. Back in the ant cave, Cremo, Namaran, and against the bone dragon in the Great Garden of Termina.

He’s always looked for a way out. There was a time when I thought even that was a deliberate act to calm his nerves down before carrying out his plans, but...

Javier concluded that Lloyd had always been genuinely afraid. He did not want to risk his life. Yet, that man still took responsibility and showed resilience in tough situations to overcome problems.

What an idiot.

Javier’s clenching became tighter as he strengthened his resolve on one side to protect his idiotic friend, regardless of the adversity that came their way. The grandmaster was determined to keep his pretentious, cowardly buddy safe.

So stop being a crybaby about your own death. You’re not going to die, and I’m going to ensure it. Even if it really comes our way, I will die in your place instead. I am willing to.

Javier breathed a small sigh again, as the fraudster’s subtle crying noise still reached his ears. The grandmaster’s heart broke as he heard the sound that leaked out through Lloyd’s palms or the blanket, whichever he was covering his face with.

Jeez.

It was a long night. Javier wished for the darkness to go away as he lifted his chin and stared at the ceiling. The night was perhaps too long.

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Javier’s wish came true, as the natural flow of time got rid of the darkness and caused the sunlight to fill the skies with brightness and warmth. The look on Lloyd’s face as he opened the door to his bedroom was also much brighter.

“What the—”

It was, until he saw Javier in the hallway and frowned. He glared across the hall and saw Javier leaning against the other side with his arms crossed and a mysterious look on his face. He was enduring the slightly dirty look Lloyd gave him, responding with a familiar yet strange composure.

“What are you doing here, so early in the morning?” Lloyd suppressed his instinct that suggested things were about to get awkward and asked.

“Phew,” Javier sighed in response.

“What? What’s that for? It’s too early in the morning for anything to have happened.”

“I was just having trouble falling asleep.”

“Really?”

“Yeah.”

“Since when were you here?”

“I only just got here.”

“Really?”

“Yeah.”

Lloyd internally breathed a sigh of relief at Javier’s nonchalant response. But the question that followed caused his heart to drop.

“Master Lloyd. What were you doing last night?”

“Huh?”

“Something is weird.”

“What is?” Lloyd asked back, cautiously wondering what Javier was talking about.

Please don’t tell me he heard my cry last night.

But Lloyd was confident he did a good job covering his mouth with his hands and face with his blanket. He was so sure he did a perfect job and didn’t allow a single sound to escape his bedroom. His heart pouted really fast as he waited for Javier’s response, which was extremely poised as usual as it rattled Lloyd’s eardrums.

“Your eyes seem a bit swollen, Master Lloyd.”

“What?”

“I’m serious. Your eyelids are much bigger than usual,” continued Javier, tilting his face to one side as if he knew something. “Did you cry... by any chance?”

Lloyd faced the biggest obstacle in his life yet. He wondered if Javier heard his cries and contemplated numerous times in a short span, only to put up another act as usual.

“Ha. What the hell are you talking about?”

“I’m only asking this because you look like it. Please don’t tell me you had a scary nightmare and cried out a river.”

“What? I’m not a kid.”

“Hmm. Really?”

“Yeah. Really. Stop asking the obvious.”

“Hmm.”

“What.”

“Something’s telling me you’re pretending.”

“Look at this guy. You’re so full of prejudice about ordinary folks with a heart. I’m not like that, mortal.”

“Really?”

“Really.”

“Tsk. And here I thought you were full of worries.”

“That, I am full of,” Lloyd replied to Javier’s sharp remark rather effortlessly, avoiding the uncomfortable area. “Who wouldn’t be, when the hell’s army is supposed to invade the estate soon?”

“You have a point.”

“Of course I do. I always do, as the epitome of hard-working individuals that do their best day and night to bring about the best possible result.”

“Hmm. I don’t think you’re using the correct words.”

“I am always correct.”

“But are you?”

“Enough bantering. Let’s get to work.”

Lloyd let out a chuckle and quickly changed the subject. He wanted to. It was true that he saw the most terrifying ending spoiler and had a nightmare about it last night, and that he had been disheartened albeit temporarily. But he did not want to show it.

I don’t want to hold anyone back.

It was his life, and he had to take care of his problems. Lloyd knew he could get some help here and there along the way, but it all came down to his decision-making in the end. He had learned this truth the hard way during his days in the tiniest rental rooms in South Korea back in the day, perhaps too early for his age.

Especially when I participated in the bioequivalence clinical trial.

He had met people with similar looks on their faces as he, as blood was drawn regularly from them during the trial. He sat among them like a lab mouse, and that was when he realized everyone there had volunteered for this opportunity to take care of themselves because no one else was going to.

And nothing has changed.

The hell's army was about to invade, and nobody else was going to stop it for him. Lloyd knew he could get some help, but it ultimately came down to his ability to end this once and for all. It was his responsibility.

And it should be. The enforced restoration of fate all began because of me. I am the one that caused all this.

Lloyd had tried his best to lead a better life and a prosperous one at that. He caused many changes that deviated from the predestined fate in the process; the estate that was bound to be ruined thrived, and the lives of those that were supposed to be screwed over changed for the better. Lloyd endeavored to bring positive changes and made multiple accomplishments. It felt great. It felt rewarding.

But he had forgotten that with every action came a responsibility. Each of his accomplishments placed a burden over his shoulders, piling up like a mountain in the end.

All this is mine to bear.

Lloyd couldn't ask someone else to bear these. He wouldn't. He strengthened his resolve once again, suppressed the feelings deep within his heart, and chuckled.

"I think I'm going to start by using the Jewel of Truth."

"What precisely would you be looking for?"

"Information about the hell's army. I want to know exactly how many soldiers we'll be facing."

Lloyd hadn’t had a chance to confirm this yet. He had discovered the estimated time of the invasion, but the size of the army wasn’t mentioned, or he had failed to identify it because of how dire the situation was within the ending spoiler.

I will have to use the jewel to uncover that bit.

He couldn’t use the ending spoiler again, as he was sure his focus would be on the same things as it was the day before. Besides, he was running low on CP; he had spent it like a financially irresponsible person recently. With the determination to save up what he can, Lloyd took Javier on a walk away from the mansion past the villages and the apartment complex on the well-paved road, towards the dam reservoir on the outskirts of the estate. That’s where Lloyd had hidden the Jewel of Truth.

Hmm. The dam seems to be well-maintained.

Lloyd habitually inspected the conditions of the dam and its vicinity. There wasn’t anything out of the ordinary.

“Alright, you stay here. I’ll be back.”

Lloyd instructed Javier to wait for him and took a huge breath, before diving into the reservoir. The sunlight shone through the surface of the water, as the estate developer saw a structure about 200 feet beneath, in the shape of a pyramid; it was the tomb of a high-ranking personnel. It was the Jewel of Truth itself.

Lloyd stood on top of the jewel, at which the key ingredient kiaora he had procured from Seoul was placed on the altar.

Good. The Jewel of Truth is just fine, and nobody seems to have used it in the meantime.

The water residue on the ingredient was even throughout, indicating no one had placed his or her hand there while he was absent from the estate.

To be fair, nobody can in this state.

This structure was located 200 feet below the water's surface, making it impossible for ordinary humans to use it even if they knew about it. Holding one's breath for an elongated period of time while enduring the water pressure required superhuman resilience.

Even sword experts at the peak of their powers would find it challenging. Without the Asrahan Core Technique, I would say one has to be a swordmaster at least, to be able to do this barely.

Lloyd was spot on.

The elves in my estate aren't greedy or ambitious, and they tend to resort to natural methods if they need to uncover a truth. Orcs don't care about the truth, as they think spending too much time on theoretical things is a waste of time and energy, and they would rather work out their muscles in that time.

Dragon Solitas was too prideful to rely on the Jewel of Truth, instead of taking matters into its own hands. Lloyd was right when he had suspected no one in the entire estate would see the need to use this item, aside from himself.

Alright, time to ask what I came here to find out.

Lloyd placed his two hands on the altar and operated his mana heart, letting the mana circle run.

Zing! The activated mana flowed into the altar and awakened the jewel from a deep slumber, shaking the structure in the process. Light fell from the sky and shone beneath the water's surface, as the mythical tomb opened its eyes and spoke out in a solemn voice that resounded in Lloyd's head amid water bubbles and bright rays.

[You, who wish to obtain a truthful answer from the Jewel of Truth. You must reveal a secret about yourself, that only you are aware of, to this world in exchange for the truth you seek.]

It was a process he had gone through before. Lloyd already knew what he was going to say.

I will reveal my truth. In fact, I secretly love and cherish all of the citizens and those that provide labor in my estate, from the bottom of my heart.

Lloyd made this confession in the usual shameless manner. It was a bit embarrassing, but it was true. That was why he had chosen to leverage this fact about him.

This would be the least damaging one out of all the secrets I harbor. Unless the citizens and laborers actually are aware of how much I love them.

Lloyd was concerned. After all, he had made astounding contributions to the estate and displayed nothing but kindness and compassion. There was a chance that a good number of people in the estate, from young to old, actually knew how much Lloyd cared about them.

Tsk, I have no one else to blame but myself. Perhaps I was being too great of a man. But I do have an alternate answer, in case this doesn't work.

Lloyd expected and waited for the jewel's negative response, preparing to give a different answer right away. The jewel finally replied.

[You have willingly shared a secret that only you had been aware of, as the price to acquire the truth you seek.]

...What?

Lloyd flinched, as the text made of light popped up on the flat side of the altar on top of the structure.

Flash! The texts glowed, as they rose through the waters past the surface, and onto the sky. They were hung over the morning sky for everyone in the vicinity to see, in bolded, enlarged fonts.

[The Jewel of Truth has spoken. Lloyd Frontera actually genuinely loves and cares for all citizens of the Frontera estate, especially those who

provide the labor on worksites, from the bottom of his heart. The Jewel of Truth only speaks the truth.]

Lloyd was absolutely flabbergasted as he silently stared at the clear texts floating in the sky. He should have been happy that his answer satisfied the conditions of using the jewel in one try, but he felt rather annoyed for some reason.

Really? No one actually knew how much I cared about them?!

Lloyd couldn't believe it. He was absolutely confident that he had shown empathy and compassion to everyone. Although he certainly displayed his blatant greed for wealth and assigned some tough tasks to the laborers from time to time, he never failed to pay them incentives on top of regular wages on time.

Isn't paying them well without withholding the wage once a perfect way of showing how much I care about them?

Lloyd just couldn't understand what was going on, and this made him sadder. But he was a resilient person. Despite the harsh truth hitting him hard, he was still keen on taking the necessary steps to get to his ultimate goal.

Ugh. Forget it. I need to hear the answer anyway.

He focused on his hands placed on the altar again and asked the question he desired to get the answer to.

I wish to know the exact size of the hell's army that is going to invade this place 90 days later.

As soon as he asked that question, his mana heart responded to something without Lloyd's intervention.

Zing! A small fraction of his mana was absorbed by the altar before it was amplified by the structure and shot out toward the surface of the water. Lloyd felt a great wave 200 feet above him, against the water enclosed by

the dam. The shockwave traveled back in the form of water pressure and hit the estate developer in the head, causing the answer he was seeking to resonate within.

[The hell’s army will invade the Frontera Estate...]

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Chapter 385: Honest Thoughts (3)

[The hell’s army will invade the Frontera Estate with 500 hell’s knights.]

What?

Lloyd flinched and nearly inadvertently let out a huge breath under water. This was that preposterous.

500 hell’s knights? Five hundred guys just like Sir Giolexius?

Sir Giolexius was more powerful than a swordmaster, requiring at least three to withstand him. The queen of the domain, who had exceeded ordinary masters by now, would have a tough time against a hell’s knight in one on one combat. Hell’s knights were terrifying enemies.

Five hundred of them...

That was greater than the number of all swordmasters officially registered in the continent of Lorasia throughout its history.

Lloyd felt chills down the spine, but the Jewel of Truth wasn’t done speaking.

[500 hell’s knight will invade the Frontera Estate at the head of the army, leading 1,500 high-ranking demons and 5,000 lesser demons behind them, followed by...]

There’s more?!

[...The lich housing the spirit of the king of hell, as the commander in chief.]

The spirit?!

Lloyd gulped anxiously and asked the jewel, which responded promptly.

[The spirit of the king of hell is the source of pure evil, and the physical body housing it in this realm is referred to as the avatar.]

...So, the king of demon will incarnate himself in the lich's body and lead the hell's army himself.

[Precisely.]

Lloyd was lost for words. He could feel the gravity of the situation all over his body.

The king of hell really is going all out.

He was ascending to this realm in the body of the avatar in the lich, leading the army himself to obliterate the Frontera Estate. But this made Lloyd curious.

But is that even possible? I thought the king of hell did not engage in battles directly with anyone else. Isn't he supposed to only exact punishment on souls based on the laws of the underworld?

[You are correct.]

Then why would he ascend himself? I know he's not showing up in his real body but in that of the lich, but isn't that against the hell's laws?

[It isn't, I'm afraid.]

Elaborate.

[Because this is what the dark sorcerer-turned-lich Lupellan asked the king of hell requested.]

...For the king of hell to incarnate himself in the lich's body and ascend?!

[That is correct. Lupellan desired your demise and the downfall of your estate. He was willing to even offer his own soul to higher beings just to cause you sufferings.]

[Lupellan made this proposition to the king of hell, who accepted it and thus was given the right to terrorize the earthly realm without violating the rules established in the underworld.]

That makes sense, because the king of hell did not take the initiative. He is only moving as per the request made by a creature of the earthly realm. Although the results are the same, the difference in the cause and motive made his move absolutely within the lawful boundaries.

Lloyd finally comprehended what was going on, after placing himself in the king of hell's shoes.

Come to think of it, that bastard was desperate to kill me. He was probably getting impatient because I kept surviving barely somehow.

That was when an unexpected creature from the earthly realm asked the king of demon to incarnate himself within the creature's body to kill Lloyd Frontera.

There's no reason for him not to accept this request. What an opportunity it was for him to take matters into his own hands.

The acceptance was a no-brainer.

And it was definitely a rare one, too. The king of hell is an outrageously powerful being, and his soul cannot be housed within just any physical shell.

Fortunately for the king of the underworld, Lupellan was a lich: an absolutely abysmal, undead sorcerer that was as mighty, if not stronger, as the hell's knight. It was perhaps a perfect body to act as the king of hell's avatar.

I wouldn't have turned it down if I was the king of hell. A lich is raised once every few millennia. The undead sorcerer that happens to have the same goal? I would take full advantage of it.

It probably felt like the opportunity of a lifetime for the king of hell. Lloyd could imagine the demon liege rushing to accept this request like someone that took a peek into the future and saw the lottery winning combination running to the convenience store.

Damn it.

A little bit of deduction showed Lloyd the big picture. He asked the jewel again.

Is there more?

[No. That's the size of the hell's army.]

With that, the Jewel of Truth became silent as though its job was done. Lloyd clenched his fist and swam up to the surface, and took a deep breath that he desperately desired.

"Whoa."

He slowly swam to the edge of the reservoir through the remaining waves, organizing his thoughts on the way.

I think I finally understand why the ending spoiler this time was so terrible like that.

Lloyd was reminded of the ending spoiler he had seen the night before. It was the most terrifying and tragic one out of all he had viewed. It was the most brutal, most gruesome, and most devastating. And on one side, the estate developer was curious.

The hell's army is supposed to invade 90 days later, which is enough time for me to prepare 2 billion liters of holy water. But I was still defeated helplessly.

This made him wonder just how great of an army that was coming. The jewel's answer clarified it for him.

This makes sense.

Thousands of demons, following five hundred hell’s knights, all led by the king of hell in the lich’s body as the avatar.

Ugh. How the hell am I supposed to win?!

Lloyd was overwhelmed by the massive difference in the military forces of two sides as he swam to the ground. It made him feel pathetic about himself for thinking of preparing two billion liters of holy water to fend the enemies off.

Can I really do this...?

Lloyd was distraught.

Or I should just end my own life.

The estate developer wondered if his death would cause all of this to cease, eventually sparing the people of the estate. As long as he was no more, the enforced fate would not be restored. That was going to keep everyone else safe. But Lloyd soon realized how stupid this idea was right away.

No. That won’t work.

Taking his own life wasn’t going to be a solution. Rather, it was going to make matters worse.

Let’s think rationally. Lupellan sacrificed his own soul to make this request to the king of hell. The king of hell was asked to incarnate himself in the lich’s body as the avatar, ultimately to kill Lloyd Frontera and to destroy the Frontera Estate.

That was what the Jewel of Truth had revealed. The estate was precisely mentioned.

My death isn’t going to stop the invasion at this point. I’ve read in the novel The Knight of Blood and Iron, about the conditions for the ascension or descension of mythical creatures like the king of hell or the archangel. A transcendent being that incarnates himself in the body of an avatar is

obligated to carry out his part of the bargain in accordance with the contract.

Failure to do so would result in the complete destruction of his original self, according to the book.

In other words, the king of hell is obligated to kill me, annihilate everyone in the Frontera Estate, and raze it to ashes.

The king of hell was going to suffer demise himself, should he fail to do so. This gave him a good reason to do his absolute best.

That explains why he's bringing 500 hell's knights. That's almost the entire hell's army.

It sent chills down Lloyd's spine again. A transcendent being like the king of hell was waging an all-out war against Lloyd, to kill him and destroy everything within the Frontera Estate. It was immensely overwhelming, making it tough for Lloyd to even breathe normally. He stopped in the middle of the lake and chuckled at the outrageousness of the situation.

"Ha. Haha."

Javier would have asked if Lloyd had completely lost it out of fear. In reality, however, it was quite the contrary. He saw a glimpse of hope.

So it's a winner-takes-all situation.

The loser of this battle was going to lose everything, including his own life. Lloyd had felt overwhelmed by the massive difference in the forces that seemed insurmountable, but now was seeing the risks that the king of hell took by ascending to this realm in the body of an avatar. The king of hell had leveraged everything he had in this war as well.

He would fail to honor the terms and conditions of the avatar contract if he can't kill me and destroy my estate, and his soul would be permanently destroyed as a result.

There was no such thing as a being that transcended even the terms and conditions of the contract. Even mythical creatures had to keep them, or suffer demise. Knowing this, Lloyd finally started seeing a ray of hope within his heart.

Alright, I can do this. I just need to make thorough preparations.

Lloyd clenched his fist and remembered the words of Sun Tzu, who once said knowing the enemy would bring victory. Since he knew the king of hell was going to invade 90 days later and the size of the opposition army, Lloyd just had to prepare accordingly, although it was definitely going to be arduous.

But I don't care. Even if I puke out my internal organs in the process, I will do it a hundred, and a thousand times.

That was the way he had lived his life up to this point. He had hustled his way into whom he was today. Lloyd wasn't going to give up here. It would be a waste of energy and efforts if he surrendered now.

Just one more obstacle.

Lloyd strengthened his resolve to hang on and triumph over it once more. He continued to take different resources into account, even after he got onto the ground and as Javier handed over the towel.

"Master Lloyd? Please don't tell me the confession that popped up in the sky is real. I can't imagine you genuinely caring for the citizens and laborers of the estate from the bottom of your heart."

Even as Javier mischievously joked around about the embarrassing truth, Lloyd remained silent and was completely lost in thoughts. In fact, he didn't even take the towel from Javier's hand and walked past him, with his eyes set on the ground and sometimes on the sky, taking into consideration all possible scenarios he could imagine in his head and mumbling like a madman, until he eventually arrived in the lord's mansion through the outskirts of the estate, the apartment complex, and a few villages, dripping water down from his wet hair and clothes.

“Lloyd? I was actually going to send for you... huh?” Count Frontera flinched and paused as Lloyd walked into the study, clearly alarmed by the look. “What in the world did you do this early in the morning?”

He was most likely astonished by how soaked his son was. The count rose from his seat with a handkerchief in his hand, and approached Lloyd to wipe the reservoir water off his face and hair. He constantly checked Lloyd from head to toe to see if there was anything wrong.

“Are you alright? What happened? You’re going to catch a cold at this rate. Have a seat here.”

He dragged him to the seat and put a blanket over Lloyd’s shoulders. The count seemed startled by the sight as he hurriedly tried to comfort his son. Perhaps this was why Lloyd inadvertently put a benevolent smile on his face as he responded.

“I’m fine.”

“You obviously aren’t. Did you trip and fall in the river or something?”

“No,” Lloyd replied.

“Then?” The count asked.

“You saw the texts that floated in the sky before, right? That was spoken by the Jewel of Truth.”

“Oh...” Count Frontera paused for a moment and asked again. “So you jumped into the lake to use the Jewel of Truth, then.”

“Yeah.”

“Why haven’t you wiped the water off your body?”

“I had a few thoughts to consider. In fact, there’s something I must speak to you about.”

“To me?”

“Yeah.”

Lloyd slowly nodded, still simulating countless scenarios in his head. The king of hell was going to invade with a force so large and fearsome, that it was going to wreak absolute havoc in the estate. Lloyd thought of ways to avoid defeat, what kind of preparations he had to make in order to make it possible, whose help he had to enlist, the resources and supplies to bring into the estate, and in which order. He thought about it all, summarized it into a single sentence, and spoke to the count.

“I need you to write a few missives, and give me an approval on something.”

“Missives and approval from me?”

“Yeah.”

“Please elaborate. I need to know what you’re up to so early in the morning.”

The count became serious as well. He knew better than anyone else that the man standing in front of him, who has taken over the body of his own son, wasn’t someone to mention something like this for naught. There always was a reason and a clear purpose for which he did something, and the Frontera Estate, along with the count and the countess, could only survive thanks to his ideas. The count was keen on doing as he says this time around again, as he cautiously waited for Lloyd’s response.

“A few missives requesting reinforcements, to the royal court of the Kingdom of Magentano, the sultanate in the east, estates of Cremo and of Namaran, the orc village alliance, the elven alliance, the mermaid kingdom in the North Sea, the tribe of Centauri in the Great Plains, et cetera.”

“What...?” The count responded in astonishment. But what followed was even more shocking.

“One more,” said Lloyd in a nonchalant, yet solemn manner. “I need your approval on breaking the dam on Lake Kapua, in the eastern mountain

range.”

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Chapter 386: Using Faith as a Weapon (1)

“I need your approval on breaking the dam on Lake Kapua, in the eastern mountain range.”

Lloyd’s tone was casual and nonchalant, but the content of his statement was enough to shock Count Frontera.

“Do you even know what you’re saying...?”

Breaking the dam meant releasing the water held in the reservoir down the mountain, like in a heavy flood. And beneath the mountain was something he cherished so much.

“I am aware that our estate will be affected. Fields developed over time, mines, waterworks and sewage, paved roads, homes, and the apartment complex are all in the potential flood zone. I’m going to do my best to minimize the damage.”

The count gulped silently. He couldn’t think of how to respond to Lloyd due to his absurd, unexpected request. However, he still managed to regain composure relatively easily, thanks to a trick he had picked up over recent years dealing with the estate developer.

He had always been this way.

Lloyd would occasionally, or even frequently, make propositions that were preposterous and unprecedented. Some of his ideas made progressives of the era look conservative. However, after taking so many factors into account, the count realized that Lloyd had made such suggestions based on solid rationale and purposes.

He must be looking way ahead.

The count was convinced that Lloyd wasn’t the type of man to throw in outrageous ideas without a good reason. He calmed himself down and asked in a poised manner.

“You are requesting to break the damn in Lake Kapua despite knowing what kind of disaster it could bring to our estate. I’d like to hear you elaborate.”

“You want to hear the reasoning, evidence, and the ultimate goal.”

“Yes,” replied the count, forcing himself to put up a smile on his face.

“I’ll start with the reasoning,” said Lloyd, wiping his wet hair with the blanket over his shoulders, hesitating and sighing once before continuing as if he was contemplating whether or not to share the grave news. “The hell’s army is going to invade our estate ninety days later.”

“Huh?” The count flinched.

“When Dragon King Verkis left our estate some time ago,” Lloyd continued explaining. “He left a magical message only to be seen by me. It said an army will ascend from the underworld and invade our estate.”

It was obviously all a lie. Lloyd was simply using the dragon king’s name in vain. But it did not really matter.

It’s not like it will cause any inconveniences for the dragon king, and he wouldn’t give a damn about it either. And it makes it much easier to move on to the next question.

Hell’s army invading the human realm was an unprecedented and therefore unforeseen event. If the count asked Lloyd how he found out about it, he could be placed in a tight spot.

I don’t have the gift of foresight or anything. And I can’t tell him I saw it through the ending spoiler.

The dragon king’s name was the only credible name he could use in vain in this situation. And it worked.

“Dragon King Verkis did?”

Count Frontera was astonished. He appeared more open to hearing what Lloyd was about to say next. The estate developer nodded and added.

“Yeah. He said he had some urgent business to take care of, and that he was sorry for being unable to help with this. I am inclined to think it’s all because I am on good terms with the dragon king, but he did tell me when they were going to attack, and the detailed size of the enemy army.”

“Holy...”

“I couldn’t believe it at first either, even though I heard it from the dragon king himself. It was that absurd an idea. So I got a second person to confirm it.”

“Who...?”

“Sir Giolexius.”

“Oh,” nodded the count, knowing whom Lloyd was referring to. “Are you talking about the hell’s knight you introduced to me yesterday?”

Count Frontera had been shocked by the presence of a spooky knight that emanated nefarious energy, accompanying Lloyd as the newest member of the Skeleton Corp.

“So the hell’s knight confirmed it for you?”

“Yeah,” Lloyd replied promptly. “I asked him if what the dragon king said was true, and he said it was, before proceeding to tell me more.”

“More?”

“Yeah. He explained the cause of all this.”

That was when Lloyd began telling the count what he had heard from Sir Giolexius after the hell’s knight signed the employment contract with him in Namaran. The count was visibly pale.

“Sir Neumann’s body... housing the soul of that evil necromancer...? He became a lich and made a request to the king of hell...?”

“Yeah. It’s all too convenient for these events to be coincidental, so I had to find a way to verify these statements.”

“How so?”

“Through the Jewel of Truth.”

The count seemed to comprehend. Lloyd put a subtle smile on his face as he pointed at how he currently looked with his eyes.

“That’s why I’m soaked like a sponge. I asked the jewel if what the dragon king and the hell’s knight revealed to me was true.”

“And they were.”

“Unfortunately, yes.”

“Alright, about the hell’s army that’s going to invade 90 days later, then.”

“What about them?”

“How big is it?”

“500 hell’s knights, leading 6,500 high-ranking and lesser demons. They will all be led by the king of hell, incarnated in the body of the lich.”

Count Frontera nearly fainted on the spot. He would have, had it not been for Lloyd’s timely intervention to hold him by his shoulders and shake him.

“Are you alright, father?”

“Huh...? Oh. Yeah. I’m so sorry.”

“It’s okay. I felt the same way when I first heard the news.”

“Whew. Alright, so releasing the waters from the dam is your idea to counter that?”

“Yeah. I have other detailed plans to go along with it, but that’s the main part.”

“Do you think... that would suffice?”

“I’m worried about that too. That’s why I plan to convert all of the freshwater there into holy water.”

“...”

“That will be two billion liters of holy water. I think it’ll be effective to a certain extent.”

“...”

The count nearly fainted again, but somehow barely managed to retain his sanity. He took a deep breath and nodded.

“Okay. I understand.”

He knew Lloyd had no intention of giving up just yet, even against 500 hell’s knights and thousands of demons, all under the command of the king of hell himself. The count saw the unshaken smile on Lloyd’s face and felt a bit ashamed.

I would have thought of fleeing first.

While Count Frontera would have fortified the estate against a sizeable enemy, the invading hell’s army supposedly was too much. In fact, each of 500 hell’s knights was powerful enough to be recorded in history individually because of its awful might.

500 of them, too, led by the king of hell incarnated in the lich’s body. I can’t imagine anyone expecting to fight back head-on.

But Lloyd was. The estate developer wasn’t showing any signs of fleeing from the insurmountable calamity. The count thought he understood why.

It’s because of the citizens. He loves and cares for his family and the people of the estate.

The count was touched. The current Lloyd wasn’t his real son and was an outsider who had no reason to help with the matters of this estate by providing for the citizens here, in reality. But that very stranger was exhibiting tremendous willpower to keep everyone safe here. The count knew Lloyd was probably scared too but overcame the fear with sheer will to protect the estate alone. That was what moved him. That was what astounded him. Except the count was wrong; Lloyd’s thoughts were elsewhere.

I will never give up on my cash cow.

For him, everything in the estate had been designed and built for him to enjoy the fruit of. The lands and the people within were all toiling under the sun day and night to bring in steady income for him, so that he could live in luxury without doing the physical labor. Maintaining this structure was vital for him to continue this way of life. Lloyd asked the count again, still harboring the dream of becoming a rich bum in his heart.

“Then you would...”

“I will do as you say.”

“R-really?”

“Is anything wrong?”

“I thought you’d suggest evacuating the citizens to a safer location at least once.”

“I’ve thought of that,” the count replied with a smile on his face.

It was true. Hell’s knights led by the king of hell incarnate were most definitely preposterous, even with the help of two billion liters of holy

water. The count was afraid for his life, and rightly so. But the look of determination of Lloyd's face to keep fighting against all odds put him to shame.

"But that will be our last resort. Let's do as you say first and make preparations as you see fit."

"I have your gratitude."

"No need."

"May I ask you to write the missives as well, then?"

"The missives requesting for reinforcements to the royal court and other estates?"

"Yeah. I will bring the drafts for you to revise later on."

"That will help. But I am still a little concerned."

"What is it?"

The count frowned as he continued.

"If the hell's army truly invades, our estate will most likely turn into the battlefield."

"Yes, it will."

"That's what worries me. The citizens may get swept by the invading army and lose their lives. That's something I can't live with even if we survive the battle."

The count was genuinely concerned. Even if they were well-prepared against the hell's army, the battle in the estate was surely going to affect the innocent, hard-working folks of this estate. Keeping them safe against the catastrophe seemed like an impossible task.

"That's why I must ask if you have thought of a plan to protect them."

Count Frontera asked with a visibly distraught look on his face. But Lloyd responded with a bright smile to reassure him.

“Of course I have. That’s why I need to be on the move.”

“Move? Where?”

“I must meet with the owner of the place to which I will evacuate our citizens.”

“What?”

The count was dumbfounded, but Lloyd did not get into details. Instead, he put up a rather bittersweet smile and added.

“I will tell you the details after I come to an agreement of the owner, which it most likely will. I’ll be back with the news as well as the drafts for you to revise. You don’t have to worry too much.”

Lloyd left the study and out of the mansion immediately, heading towards the village in the center past the marketplace that was bustling with activities and obviously thriving. He then arrived in front of the smith’s workshop, at which the *owner* of the refuge resided.

“How goes your attempt to be less terrible of a craftsman?”

“...”

In the corner of the workshop was a man, a red dragon in fact, heavily focused on crafting something with glass. He stared into the glass sphere and chuckled.

“What do you think?”

Solitas, the red dragon, held a beautifully glowing glass ball in his hand. But Lloyd could already see its blemishes even from a glance.

“Uh... I think that ball is a bit lopsided.”

“...What?”

“It looks more like a potato on one side.”

“Huh?”

“That wasn’t intended, was it?”

“Ugh...”

“So you haven’t become less terrible.”

Solitas glared at Lloyd balefully for pointing it out. But the estate developer did not mind the dirty look.

“But it’s okay. You’ve definitely improved compared to the beginning. Keep working on your skills and you’ll be fine in a few years.”

“D-do you think so?”

“Of course I do. Since you’re working with glass already, I think you can even start producing some relic artifacts soon.”

“Really?”

“Yeah. And I’m sure you’re going to find a gorgeous lady to court shortly, too.”

“Haha, nothing will make me happier.”

Solitas was delighted, and genuinely. Due to the law that Dragon King Verkis had made, dragons were now prohibited from raiding other races including humans, and thus had to produce their own artifacts and valuables to add to their hoard. Without them, they couldn’t feed their hatchlings properly. The problem was, Solitas had absolutely no skill whatsoever when it came to craftsmanship. The red dragon couldn't bring treasure into his lair, and without the hoard, he couldn’t find himself a girlfriend, let alone a suitable wife. It was truly devastating for him to realize that he was going to die single until he met this human Lloyd.

Thanks to him, I became an assistant to the master dwarf smith, learning the trade under him. Although it's taking me a lot longer than others to work on delicate things, I am a dragon blessed with a long lifespan. A few years of learning is like the blink of an eye for me.

Solitas only had to endure a few more years to learn the trade, and he was going to be an attractive bride for any groom. That hopeful thought brought an honest smile to the red dragon.

I wonder where my future wife is, and what she's doing right now. Ah...

His heart began to pout like a man in love already. That was when Lloyd intervened to seal the deal.

"That's what I was going to get to. Have you ever heard of something called a blind date?"

"...A what?"

"It's a meeting arrangement between two people that haven't met before, but with the intent to see if things could go romantically. I think I can set you up with someone if you could do me a favor."

Lloyd's gentle voice sounded like honey and butter. The idea of going on a blind date with a mysterious lady that Solitas had always dreamed of began to cause his dragon heart to beat like a drum.

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Chapter 387: Using Faith as a Weapon (2)

Blind date was a magical term that touched the hearts of every single person seeking a romantic partner. It was like a battlefield of opportunity for some, tragic defeat for some, and glory and blessing for others. It certainly made the heart of Solitas, the red dragon, beat fast despite being quite new to this word. The dragon was genuinely delighted from his heart.

He said he's going to set me up with someone. I suppose that's what the term blind date means. Is that similar to a marriage arrangement as humans call it?

Solitas got a little anxious from the excitement.

"Really?"

"Most likely."

"Does that mean I can get married and start a family too, once you set me up with someone?"

"That depends on you, Lord Solitas."

"I see. So your responsibility only stretches to the actual arrangement itself."

"Precisely."

"Alright, who is it then?"

"Do you mean who's going to come in the blind date?"

"Yeah."

"I can't tell you that."

"Why not?"

“Because I haven’t even explained what kind of favor I needed.”

Solitas realized he was rushing a bit, and took a step back.

“Ahem, ahem. Okay, what is it you wish from me?”

“It may be difficult or easy depending on how you see things.”

“Wait. You’re not going to ask me to incinerate the excretions of creatures that live here again, are you?”

“No way. Do I look like someone who will make such a nasty inquiry?”

Solitas thought Lloyd definitely did, but kept quiet anyways as the estate developer continued in a shamelessly composed manner.

“The hell’s army is actually going to invade this place about three months later.”

“What?”

“It’ll probably be a huge one too, and this estate will most definitely suffer.”

“Do you want me to join the battle?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“I wish to evacuate the citizens of Frontera Estate and Lacona Barony to your lair for a few days while the estate is under attack.”

“...What?” The dragon frowned uncomfortably. “That many humans... to my lair...?”

“Yes, milord. I think ten to fifteen days should suffice.”

“I didn’t even approve.”

“I think you will, though.”

“Why would I be willing to do that for lowly humans?”

“Not for the humans. I was hoping you’d accept for the blind date.”

“But how dare you even mention my lair in the deal! Did you take me for a fool, and honestly expect me to let those filthy creatures into my home?!”

“I will make everyone take a good bath prior to the relocation.”

“No. I can’t imagine what they would do to my lair.”

“Eat, and sleep, at max.”

“My lair isn’t an inn.”

“But you’ll get to experience the wonderfully joyous blind date.”

“Don’t even think you could degrade my lair by offering something like that.”

“It will be an exhilarating blind date.”

“That’s the same as degrading me.”

“It will be a thrilling blind date.”

“If you intend to argue with me, then I oblige.”

“An immensely romantic blind date.”

“How dare you...”

“A tremendously heart-warming blind date.”

“...F-fine.”

“Oh, yeah.”

Lloyd chuckled with a mischievously evil grin on his face as Solitas's face turned red from the embarrassment and excitement simultaneously. For the red dragon, this was an offer he couldn't resist.

Phew. A blind date...? I really didn't see this coming. What clothes do I wear that day? Or should I go in my original form instead? I'll have to wipe my horns and scales to make them look good. Wax them and put them through light fire, then apply cold water and wipe it off with a soft towel. Oh, and I can even coat my scales with glass after the fire and water treatment. Yeah, I think that will do.

The blind date hadn't even been arranged, but the red dragon was already planning ahead. Despite not knowing whom he was going to meet, Solitas began daydreaming as if they had gone on dates more than a hundred times. He wondered how to draft the marriage certificate, contemplated on the shape of the ring to be exchanged, and decided going to the beach was the best option for the honeymoon. He was basically laying out the plans for a wonderful family life from A to Z.

"Then you accept my offer, right?"

Flap! The flapping noise of a piece of paper could be heard amidst the gentle voice of Lloyd.

When Solitas snapped out of daydreaming, he was holding a document in his hand.

"What's this?"

"A short-term rental agreement."

"Short term... what?"

"Yeah. It basically says you're going to allow citizens of Frontera and Lacona to stay in your lair for up to fifteen days."

"What kind of bull--"

"Blind date."

“Do I sign on the bottom?”

“Yeah, thank you.”

Lloyd put up a genuine smile of satisfaction only after the deal was sealed with the signature.

Good. I got the safety of the citizens secured.

He was finally able to breathe a sigh of relief, as Solitas’s lair was quite a distance away from the estate and certainly large enough to house everyone, not to mention the decent level of fortification that could be expected from any dragon’s lair. There was not a shred of a doubt the people were going to be protected there. They weren’t going to be swept away by the battle in the estate.

Thank goodness.

Lloyd was relieved, but there still remained a problem.

“Alright, when will you be setting me up with a blind date then?”

“I will, after the more imminent issue is taken care of.”

“You mean the invasion?”

“Yeah.”

“What the hell have you been doing, that you’re being attacked by the hell’s army?”

“That’s what I’d like to know.”

“Anyhow, your death means I won’t get to meet with the lady.”

“Most likely.”

“Don’t die then.”

“Thank you for your blessings.”

“One more thing.”

“I’m listening.”

“About the woman you were going to set me up with,” said the red dragon, in an excited voice. “Can you give me a hint, like how she looks like and stuff?”

“...Uh, not really.”

“Why not?”

“Because the element of mystery is what makes the blind date all the more exciting.”

“D-do you think so?”

“Of course it does.”

It didn’t. Sharing a bit of information about the partner prior to the blind date was the norm, but Lloyd actually couldn’t this time.

Because I don’t know yet either!

In reality, Lloyd had just brought up what he thought was going to work best on persuading the red dragon and mentioned it without making any preparations. But he couldn’t think of a better solution.

Dealing with the invading army is more imminent a problem. I need to save the people of my estate.

The urgent issue at hand was too great for him to think of details in the evacuation plan.

I’ll have to look for a fine single female dragon who is interested after the battle. God, I hope I can find one.

While Lloyd thought it was sort of irresponsible of him, he did not have a choice. But he maintained composure on the outside and graced his appearance with a trustworthy and confident smile.

“Anyhow, the citizens will relocate about 85 days from today. I will tell them to gather in one place, so please cast a mass teleport spell on them.”

“All of them at once?”

“Is that going to be difficult?”

“My dragon heart is going to be depleted of energy.”

“Is it not possible then?”

“No. That is not what I said.”

“Okay. Then I will leave them in your capable hands.”

“Fine. Just don’t forget to set me up with a gorgeous lady.”

“Of course.”

The contract to relocate the citizens was sealed between Lloyd and Solitas. With this issue resolved, the estate developer could now move on to the next.

Alright, I got the safety of people secured. Now I need to lay the foundation for the usage of holy water.

In fact, Lloyd had already thought of a way to utilize the two billion liters of holy water to be made from the tears of the angel of thrones. He climbed the eastern mountains immediately and went to Lake Kapua, at the sandy shore of which Bibeong was enjoying a nice sunbath.

“Ah, good to see you. I was actually looking for you.”

“...Bibeong?”

Bibeong opened one of his eyes while still lying on its belly, as though it had just woken up from a nap. Lloyd began explaining what was going to happen, from the invasion of the army to the two billion liters of holy water and what needed to be done in order to use it.

“...So I was hoping to break the dam, and I thought your approval was absolutely necessary.”

The creation of this reservoir, in fact, was Bibeong’s doing. It had built a dam like any beaver would in this area, and due to the sheer size of this structure, it had formed a huge lake that rivaled any big artificial lake within South Korea. In a way, Bibeong was the rightful owner of this property.

“Would that be okay...?”

Lloyd asked this question with an element of concern. Bibeong wasn’t really loyal to him; it had only agreed to provide labor as necessary to get on the good side of Bangul. There was a chance that this creature could decline Lloyd’s request, thwarting this plan before it could even begin. Lloyd wondered if he had to leverage Bangul’s presence again to seal the deal.

“Bibeong!”

Bibeong’s response, however, was unexpected.

“R-really? You will let me?”

“Bibeong! Bibeong!”

“Of course you approve, because the estate is in danger?”

“Bibeong!” Bibeong nodded robustly again and added. “Bibeong! Bibeong! Bibeong! Bibeong!”

Bibeong explained that it wasn’t because of Bangul this time, but because it trusted Lloyd and what he had done thus far. The creature was willing to

place his faith in the estate developer and asked Lloyd to build the dam together after the problem was taken care of.

“...Thank you,” said Lloyd, as that was the only thing he could.

After the approval was given, Lloyd could freely and lightheartedly measure the dimensions of the lake and the dam. He scanned all terrains from the dam to the estate and analyzed the geography in depth in order to minimize the damage to the estate even after the flood of two billion liters of holy water.

It’s going to be a massive flood. I must ensure the damages to the villages and facilities are minimized, while sweeping through the hell’s army with the water.

It was virtually impossible to prevent any sort of damage, but he still couldn’t allow the lands to get devastated along with the hell’s army just to claim victory.

I can’t allow a huge disaster like the one in Vajont Dam in Italy. That’s the last thing I want.

He had toiled under the sun and endeavored restlessly to develop this estate. The lands and facilities were all wonderfully improved over time. He did not want to lose them.

I must build a pathway through which the two billion waters of holy water could travel, and with the least amount of waste possible. And I can’t afford to spend too much time building this.

It wasn’t going to be an easy task by any means. In fact, it was perhaps the most arduous challenge he faced yet.

But I can do this. I have the measurement skill as well as the engineering skill. I can trust the visual simulation feature. It’s definitely possible. I mustn’t give up. I must hustle harder.

Lloyd focused on getting accurate measurements of many different areas throughout the day, causing his eyes to turn red from fatigue. He would still restlessly walk and sometimes travel on Ggoming's back, in order to cover as wide a range as possible and with as much detail as he could. He left no stone unturned and gathered the necessary data. He then devised a detailed plan and a rough draft of the structure.

It's basically a special form of river embankment.

Lloyd used all of his knowledge about his particular structure he could think of, from the main and secondary levee to be installed in the pathway for two billion liters of holy water and the cross levee to hold the pathway in place, to the open levee to control the amount of flood and the overflow levee to mitigate the accidental derailing of the flood. He thought of many different structures and took combined ideas to come up with the best construction plan, while simultaneously preparing for the next task: informing the citizens of the estate about the invasion of the hell's army.

I can't keep this secret forever.

With just ninety days of time remaining, he was going to need every help he could get. In order to enlist the help of the citizens, Lloyd had to share the news with everyone.

And in order to evacuate them. I can't expect them to just relocate out of the blue.

Lloyd knew the people were going to panic if they weren't notified of what was going on in advance, causing way more variables to come into play. He did not want that.

It's better to inform them now, so as to minimize the confusion.

People were going to be flustered and even devastated for sure, and some citizens were definitely going to depart. It was going to be a scary moment. Some might even permanently abandon their homes to seek refuge elsewhere, like in the event of an apocalypse. But Lloyd was willing to risk that.

It's not like I can ask them to remain here when their lives are literally on the line. I can't force them to follow my plan all the way and evacuate to the lair of Solitas. It's their choice.

Even if some citizens would turn their backs on Lloyd, and even if that number was going to exceed his expectations, the estate developer continued to convince himself not to get disappointed or disheartened. He kept strengthening his resolve when a notification rang within his head suddenly.

Ding-dong!

"Huh?"

An expected message popped up on a window in front of his eyes.

[Citizens of Frontera Estate are appalled.]

[Due to the statement of Angel Raphael, who cannot lie, the citizens found out about the invasion of the hell's army.]

[However, no one in the estate is willing to flee and move to a different area.]

[Instead, they are genuinely grateful to you for having made preparations to evacuate them first, and pledged their support for your plan.]

[Every citizen of the estate is strengthening his or her resolve in unity, to help and support Master Lloyd for everything he had done for them. They will never let you bear the burden all alone.]

What in the world...

Messages continued to pop up in front of his eyes, like spam internet browser tabs. Lloyd's eyes widened from the unexpected shock. This was when he realized small miracles that he had never taken into account were taking place, slowly but surely.

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Chapter 388: Using Faith as a Weapon (3)

Two hours ago, when Lloyd was still conversing with Bibeong near Lake Kapua in the middle of the eastern mountain range, Raphael the angel was showing his characteristic kindness to the citizens of Frontera Estate beneath the hills.

Rub! Pinch!

“Alright. One more.”

Raphael’s hands were busy carrying the bucket full of cow milk to the side while handing over the empty one to the cowherd, who was just as occupied.

Rub! Pinch! The steaming cow milk began filling the empty bucket again, bringing a satisfactory smile to the herd’s face.

“You really didn’t have to,” said the cowherd graciously. “I hope I’m not causing an inconvenience, lord angel.”

“Please don’t say that. I’m helping because I can, and I know you hurt your back last month,” replied the angel of thrones with a benevolent smile. “Carrying heavy buckets full of milk is going to aggravate your injury. That may lead to chronic back pain since you tend to get hurt in the same area.”

“Common folks like us get hurt and injured all the time.”

“Please don’t degrade yourself. You must love yourself and cherish your own body.”

“Hahaha, I understand. Thank you so much. How can I repay you?”

“Hmm. If you’re going to invite me to a meal, I wouldn’t decline.”

“Awesome, because the potatoes I dug up recently are really nice and big.”

“Potatoes. That sounds wonderful.”

Raphael's smile became more apparent, making the labor under the sun all the more enjoyable. The breeze was just adequate, and the sunlight was appropriately warm. The occasional shade cast by clouds in the sky made this a delightful day in the village.

The blemishes in the human realm are what make this world a beautiful place, Raphael thought.

It wasn't always perfect. Rainclouds would sometimes fill the skies, causing unexpected, heavy rains to fall shortly before the sun would shine again. It was definitely different from the heavenly realm, in which everything was always flawless and perfect.

Same with potatoes. Some are ugly in appearance, some taste bad, some are poorly maintained, while others have sprouts. But that's what makes perfect potatoes valuable and astounding.

Raphael carried the buckets full of cow milk and headed to the cowherd's home, genuinely appreciating this world a little more.

"By the way," said the cowherd all of a sudden as they walked. "I don't know if I'm asking the right person, but have you heard the news about Master Lloyd?"

Raphael turned his head and noticed the cowherd was staring at him.

"Lloyd Frontera?"

"Yes, lord angel."

"Hmm. That is a peculiar question. You and I both know he recently returned to the estate."

"That, I am aware of. It's just that I found something... strange."

"Strange?" The angel asked.

"He supposedly loves and cares about all citizens of the estate from the bottom of his heart," replied the cowherd with an awkward facial

expression.

“Oh. You’re talking about the message that was shared through the Jewel of Truth.”

“Yeah.”

“Was it that surprising?”

“Haha, I suppose so,” said the cowherd with another awkward chuckle. “I always knew how much Young Master Lloyd cared about the estate since he despises being in the deficit. But to find out he truly cares for people like us... I really did not see that coming.”

“Why, though?”

“Because there is no need for him to,” said the cowherd immediately to the angel’s question. “People like us were born to work hard, pay taxes, and get conscripted to fight in battles in times of war. That is our duty in life. We are nothing more than cattle, if not worse, in the eyes of noblemen and women. We are mere numbers that enrich their estate by providing labor and other services as necessary, and easily replaceable.”

“But Lloyd Frontera was different.”

“Yes. Count and Young Master Frontera were all different. Young Master Lloyd actually used to be rather... mean in the past, but he changed suddenly one day. He began treating us like humans and even stepped up to keep us safe in times of crisis. We thought he was just taking care of his assets so he could gain something from us later on, but we were honestly grateful to serve a nobleman who was still miles better than others.”

“Haha. So none of you knew how he genuinely felt about you.”

“Yes. We really had no idea that he truly cared.”

“You must have been delighted to find out.”

“No,” the cowherd shook his head adamantly, staring at the angel. “Quite the contrary. We actually are worried.”

“Worried?”

“Because it feels like Young Master Lloyd keeps pushing himself to take care of things all alone.”

“Lloyd Frontera is...?”

“Yes. I actually saw this morning, too.”

“What did you see?”

“He was riding on the back of Sir Ggoming, and was headed towards the eastern mountains alone,” said the cowherd, pointing at the hills. “The look on his face wasn’t that of someone going on a picnic. He is most definitely planning to bear heavy responsibilities all by himself, as he has done time and again. That is what we common folks are unhappy and concerned about, as much as we’re curious. Do you know what Young Master Lloyd is up to these days, by any chance?”

“Uh, well...” Raphael hesitated and was reminded of the fact that he was a being that could not possibly lie. In fact, he would immediately give it away if he was being deceptive. “...I do.”

The fiery halo behind him was going to go out as soon as he spoke a lie, and the cowherd was going to notice it right away. The angel of thrones reluctantly nodded, causing the cowherd to open his eyes widely.

“I knew it. So Master Lloyd is making some sort of preparations again, without telling us?”

“Uh... Yes.”

Raphael’s head dropped. He knew he definitely played the cowherd’s game and lost it. He hadn’t expected the cowherd to elaborate on his guess and just ask for the angel’s confirmation, completely disabling him from giving partially truthful answers.

“I will not tell you full details, because that’s Lloyd Frontera’s job,” said the angel, letting out a bitter chuckle. “But to sum it up, demonic creatures are set to invade this estate.”

“...What?!”

The cowherd came to a complete stop, as well as other cattlemen who were following them from the side. They all turned their faces to the angel and checked the fiery halo, which was still burning like a torch. The angel of thrones knew he was in a tight spot.

“Lloyd Frontera is doing his best in order to fend off the attack and protect everyone in the state. Preparations are being made, the first of which was to evacuate every citizen of the estate to a safe place.”

“Finding a way to evacuate us is the first thing he did?”

“Yeah.”

It was true. The angel of thrones had coincidentally seen Lloyd and Solitas conversing about something, which was overheard albeit little.

“Lloyd Frontera has already prepared a haven to keep all of you safe. He seemed absolutely relieved. I suppose he had been really worried.”

“...”

The cowherd became speechless, as did the other cattlemen. After a brief moment of silence, the cowherd spoke again, this time towards his brothers.

“I think we have to do something to help.”

“I agree, big brother.”

“Likewise.”

“Me, too.”

Other cattle-herding brothers nodded with a look of seriousness on their faces, putting down the buckets full of milk from their hands. The angel of thrones became a bit anxious at the sight.

Gosh, I hope I haven't made things worse.

Raphael wondered if he was supposed to wait until Lloyd revealed all this at the right time. He worried whether or not his rash responses would cause Lloyd some harm, and ultimately get in the way of his plan. The intense pressure and the looks on the faces of the cattle-herding brothers made the angel extremely uncomfortable, causing him to attempt to rectify the situation.

"Please don't act rashly, all of you. The first thing Lloyd Frontera ever did was to make a preparation to evacuate the citizens and laborers, so don't be so terrified. Remain calm, and follow Lloyd's plan to—"

"We're not terrified, lord angel."

"Huh?"

"And we have no intention of acting rashly, either."

"I-is that so?"

"Yes," all of the cattle-herding brothers nodded simultaneously.

"I'm actually upset at Young Master Lloyd for this," said the oldest brother. "He's been trying to bear the burdens all by himself again, finding a safe haven for us. Do we get in the way that much?"

"Well..."

"Why couldn't he just tell us straight away and ask for our help? Did he really think we were going to abandon the estate and run away? I'd be so disappointed if he thought of us that way. Don't you think, brothers?"

The oldest cowherd turned his head and looked at other cattlemen, who nodded and agreed immediately.

“I agree, big brother. I appreciate Young Master Lloyd’s kindness and all, but this is not cool.”

“That’s right. If he really thought we were going to abandon him just because of the terrifying news, he’s mistaken.”

“Definitely. Why couldn’t he just ask us for help?”

“Youngest is right. I don’t think we can sit idly by.”

The oldest brother glanced at the youngest and spoke again.

“Youngest. You’re the quickest on feet among us. Why don’t you run to the village and spread this news?”

“To whom? Everyone I meet?”

“Yeah. I’m sure every citizen will react the same way.”

“Okay. I’ll be back.”

The youngest cattleman was down the road towards the village even before the angel of thrones had a chance to intervene. The youngest reached the village center and began shouting out something, causing the villagers to murmur and head to other neighborhoods to share what they had heard. The news spread like wildfire, eventually reaching everyone in the Frontera Estate.

Most people of the estate responded in a similar way. They were upset because Lloyd hadn’t asked them for help instead of trying to take care of the problem all by himself. They were complaining because they weren’t given a chance to protect the lands they loved and cared for as well. Workers put down the eggs from the chicken’s nest, stopped picking weed from the field and dusted off the dirt, placed on the ground the axe and the saw they were using to cut down trees in the woods, and took off the blacksmith aprons. They gathered near the lord’s mansion by the time Lloyd descended from the mountain.

“What the...”

And he was astonished. The estate developer had been taking measurements in various areas of the eastern mountain until only a moment ago when he saw unexpected messages pop up like spam in front of his eyes. He rode on Ggoming's back and quickly got down to the estate, only to see a huge crowd of people as if there was a revolt or something.

"Young Master Lloyd! Is it true the hell's army is going to invade?"

"Why didn't you tell us?"

"Did you really think we would abandon our homes and run away if you did?"

"We're so disappointed, Master Lloyd!"

"Why can't we ever help you for once?"

"Why do you always try to take care of things all by yourself? You're making us uncomfortable!"

"We don't want to be mere obstacles that get in your way!"

All citizens burst out and threw in one complaint after another, immediately upon seeing Lloyd. They clenched their fists, raised their voices, and shouted out that they could contribute to the welfare of the estate. They demanded him to stop bearing the burdens all alone.

"Wow..."

Lloyd was flabbergasted by the unexpected surprise. But he managed to retain his composure, albeit barely, and turned his head towards the angel of thrones, who was standing on one side with an uncomfortable smile on his face.

Did you tell them this...? Lloyd asked through his eyes.

I'm so sorry. This isn't what I intended, the angel replied awkwardly. Lloyd could tell what had transpired right away.

So, the Angel of Thrones spilled the beans about the invasion of hell's army because he couldn't tell any lies.

But the response from the public wasn't what he had anticipated. It wasn't unpleasant by any means.

I was actually contemplating how I could deliver this message without making them terrified. I really thought the majority of them would panic.

He had expected the citizens to lose hope in fear and chaos and confusion to ensue. He had thought some people would abandon the estate permanently because they had no faith in the evacuation plan. The fear could easily spread among them like a plague, Lloyd had genuinely believed.

But what's this...?

Lloyd took a good look at the crowd. Nearly all citizens of the estate from farmers, cattlemen, caretakers, lumberjacks, and smiths, to pub owners and maidservants of the lord's mansion, were there like soldiers laying siege to a fortification, grumbling and complaining about something he had never anticipated.

They want to help with the difficulties. They don't want to be seen as obstacles that get in the way.

They wanted to overcome problems together. They wanted to suffer together. They wanted to be a part of it all. That was what the citizens were asking in unity.

Why the heck would you want to suffer together? Is this some kind of a new, popular activity?

Lloyd was absolutely flustered. He actually couldn't comprehend.

Why, when this isn't going to benefit them at all?

Lloyd asked these questions despite having seen the answer from the pop-up messages.

It's probably related to the achievements and titles I have acquired thus far.

Lloyd suspected the accomplishments he had made thus far had all contributed to this and created synergy, causing the citizens to behave in a way he couldn't comprehend.

But I suppose I am truly grateful for it.

Lloyd inadvertently chuckled. He had actually been concerned about citizens fleeing before he could evacuate them, unwilling to cooperate with his plan, and causing difficulties in the plan. With this, however, Lloyd could rest assured.

Honestly, this works for me.

Lloyd took a good look at the citizens that demanded to stand together in a crisis like this and burned with the passion to make them work overtime like retail workers in the holiday season.

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Chapter 389: Calm Before the Storm (1)

Honestly, this works for me.

Lloyd took a good glance at the citizens with sparkly eyes, as the people demanded to be a part of the problem-solving crew and expressed their complaints against Lloyd for trying to fix everything alone in unity, near the entrance to the lord's mansion. It was an absolutely unexpected turn of events, helping Lloyd think of new ideas he could incorporate into the strategy.

Alright. Let's do this.

Flap!

Lloyd made Ggoming land atop a huge boulder and stood on the back of the creature so everyone could see him. He then proceeded to deliver a speech.

"Ahem. Everyone, please calm down. I heard all of your demands and complaints. But do you realize that the hell's army is going to invade soon?"

"Yes!"

"Of course we do!"

The citizens responded robustly. Lloyd waited until the noise subsided and asked again.

"Do you realize what kind of terrifying creatures they are?"

"Yes!"

"Of course we do!"

The citizens shouted even louder, causing Lloyd to chuckle.

"Whoa. I understand. I gratefully accept."

Lloyd did not try to appear modest or honorable by denying their help even once, because he needed all the help he could get at the moment. In fact, the construction to utilize two billion liters of holy water required a decently large workforce.

“Very well. Please calm down. I understand why you were all upset at me. I will never try to take care of things all by myself in situations like this again. Does this work?”

Everyone nodded, and Lloyd continued.

“Thank you so much, all. Now, please allow me to explain everything in detail. I was planning to deliver the speech after some preparations had been made, but here we are. It is true. The hell’s army will invade our beloved estate about 90 days later, consisting of 500 hell’s knights, thousands of demons, and the king of hell in lich’s body.”

Silence ensued, shortly before small murmuring voices of insecurity were exchanged. Lloyd was still impressed by the lack of blatant fear and continued.

“That is why I made the plan to evacuate everyone. All of you will relocate to the lair of a dragon 85 days later.”

The murmur became louder as Lloyd added.

“Meaning, we have 85 days left to prepare for the invasion. We’re going to use that time wisely to lay the foundation to protect our homes and jobs.”

Lloyd spoke each word clearly and loudly, making eye contact with as many people as he could.

“The construction will begin soon. We will have to dig up some ground, build levees, construct waterways, and lay several traps on the suspected enemy travel route. And we need a lot of laborers for that. I need your help. Are you ready for touch physical labor?”

“You bet we are!” The citizens replied right away.

“It isn’t going to be easy. In fact, it will be really tough,” continued Lloyd. “But the toiling under the sun this time will be to protect your own homes and lives, not to protect the count, me, or the estate. Are you willing to put in the effort?”

“Yeah!”

The answer was even louder this time. Lloyd used the opportunity to add even more ridiculous job descriptions.

“Good. You’d better be ready, because the construction will be always happening, on three different shifts, without a day off. You’ll have to work overtime and night shifts frequently. Should we run out of time, we’ll turn that into two different shifts with overloaded work hours. And with that, I would like to make a promise.”

Lloyd took another good glance at the citizens, who were teeming with the passion to do whatever it took to protect their homes. The estate developer reassured them from the bottom of his heart.

“I will not treat your efforts as voluntary work. Please fill out the clock-in and clock-out times as you come to work and leave. Put your name on the list when you’re working overtime and night shifts. You won’t be compensated properly without doing so. Understood? Nothing is free in this world, and that principle applies to your labor as well. Your sweats from hard work are not free by any means.”

Lloyd was serious about this. He had no intention of exploiting the citizens by taking advantage of their goodwill.

They may be burning with passion right now, but they will start losing morale a few days into hard work on site. After weeks of overtime, they won’t be so enthusiastic anymore.

Lloyd composedly calculated the risks and made the prediction based on his wisdom and experience.

That's in human nature. We believe we can do anything when we're so fired up, but once things get a bit difficult, we look for ways to get out of the tight spot.

Lloyd saw the enthusiasm as momentary, despite the passion and excitement the citizens displayed. The willingness to provide voluntary labor and thus contribute to the welfare of the estate was going to wane soon after toiling on site to fatigue without getting much rest. Lloyd knew this side of human nature extremely well.

I must establish these rules right now.

Even though Lloyd was the lord's son and the citizens were commoners of this estate, and even though the relationship between the lord and the people in this particular place was built on trust unlike ordinary fiefdoms, Lloyd still believed both parties needed each other based on business needs. Depending solely on the goodwill of the other party was going to bite him back later on, he believed.

"I will relay the details about the teams, work schedule, daily wage, and overtime pay to each village shortly. Please thoroughly read them when you get the notice. And do not ever forget that your labor is not free. You must receive appropriate compensation for the services you provide. I will make sure you do. So, let's do our absolute best to overcome this crisis and become wealthy all together!"

"...Hooray...?!"

The citizens were dumbfounded but inadvertently rejoiced along with Lloyd's shout anyways. They had felt their passion and enthusiasm subside a little at the mention of wage for the labor, but soon came back to their senses upon hearing proper compensation for their work."

My son is studying abroad in Cremo. I wanted to send him to the royal academia, which will definitely cost a lot more money.

I've been concerned about the cost of medication for my mother.

I want to buy a home.

I was hoping to go to a fancy place for our honeymoon.

If we can get paid handsomely for the regular and overtime shifts...

Young Master Lloyd is very meticulous and precise when it comes to money.

I heard the guys at the engineering corp never failed to get paid on time.

If we do our best this time...

I can't wait to make some money!

Money! Money!

Lloyd noticed the sparkles in the eyes of the people, as the noise near the lord's mansion became even louder. The difference was that while the previous shouts had been based on their raw passion and enthusiasm, they were now inspired by capitalistic needs.

"Yeaaaaaaah!!"

And Lloyd added fuel to this fire.

"Who wants to be rich?!"

"Meeeeeeee!!"

The concern he had about how to share the news of the invasion had been taken care of, just like that. With the promise of cooperation by the citizens, Lloyd did not hesitate to work on the details.

Now's the time to do the work, before the passion dies down.

Lloyd knew that momentum and morale were key factors in getting something done and that they often drew out unexpectedly huge performances from those who were involved. He believed that this was such an instance, and endeavored even more diligently than usual. He

reminded himself of the days in which he went to class in the morning and worked later in the evening seven days a week. He remembered the blood he spilled from working too hard. Lloyd worked on measurements and designing during the sun, and forming teams and work schedules for laborers after sunset.

After five days of time, he was finally ready to start the project.

Holy... I'm about to die.

Lloyd felt overwhelming dizziness in his head, with the completed construction plan in front of him. He hadn't gotten a minute of sleep for the past five days, operating the Asrahan Core Technique to endure the physical limits.

Because I have no time to waste. I need to get this project done in 80 days, considering when I need to evacuate the citizens. While freezing time could come in handy, it definitely seemed feasible to get everything completed in 80 days even without the use of RP. Except there is no room for any mistake whatsoever.

One mistake could cause the two billion liters of water to sweep through the villages and facilities, or even cause the waters to go to absolute waste without inflicting damage to the hell's army. That was the last thing he wanted, so Lloyd perfected his plan while keeping the simulation feature on the entire time. Thanks to these efforts, Lloyd's stamina was as low as that of someone who had just run three marathons in a row.

But the real work begins now!

Lloyd wondered if he was going to die of fatigue well before the hell's army invaded the estate, but brushed these concerns aside and commenced the construction project. Digging up the foundation for the waterway from Lake Kapua to the outskirts of the estate, through which the two billion liters of holy water was going to travel, went smoothly thanks to huge contributions by Bibeong and Draggy.

"Bibeong! Bibeong!"

Shriek! Growl!

A rare summoned creature and bone dragon, both of which boasted of couple hundred feet of statures, were especially great at large-scale digging albeit lacking a bit of precision. Large trees and boulders were removed each time Bibeong dug out a chunk of the soil with his claws, and a few feet of trenches were made each time Draggy went to work. After the two colossal beasts did the initial work, the team of laborers got to work.

“Team One! Get to work!”

“Alright!”

A team of laborers consisting of citizens would begin working on site, perfecting the rough pathway to be under the plan. They got rid of the dirt on the side and kept the vicinity tidy, while the engineering corps built levees using the removed dirt.

I cannot control the flow of water entirely just by digging up the ground.

Because the path between the lake and the estate was not in a straight line, Lloyd had to incorporate the natural terrain of the mountains as much as he could in order to minimize the actual work by laborers. The levees on the outer edge of the corners were absolutely necessary to keep the water from overflowing and thus getting wasted.

Every individual of the estate endeavored in unity. Javier’s beautiful face was covered in dirt. Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, and Ggoming moved around restlessly to do things that were too difficult for humanoid laborers. Orc warriors flexed their muscles as they carried heavy items. Elves offer prayers to the removed trees and shrubs to calm the spirits down. Hell’s knight Sir Giolexius and the skeletal corp cracked their joints as they provided labor. Angel Raphael picked up the pickaxe and the shovel from time to time, in between sessions during which he shed tears of laughter from Lloyd’s dad jokes.

The absolutely rewarding project of destroying nature continued. The shape of the moon changed as days passed, leaves turned green after a month, and

the new season came after two months into the project. The construction was completed exactly on the 79th day after it kicked off, as the cries of cicadas filled the mountains.

Whoa...

Lloyd wiped the sweat off his forehead and took a deep breath, before lifting his chin to stare at the end of the deep and wide waterway.

Ha. It looks more like a humongous valley.

Lloyd inadvertently let out a bittersweet chuckle at the splendor of the structure that was definitely too vast to be called a mere waterway. It was so grand that strangers would see it and believe this terrain was natural. The width of the opening, in fact, was greater than an ordinary football field.

Except I minimized its width as much as I could. That much water cannot travel through a pathway that's any narrower than this. I can't afford to waste any of that, because that's going to cause chaos.

The abundance of water could even destroy the pathway here and there, increasing the amount of loss significantly. Controlling water would virtually be impossible as per the simulations he ran.

But we did a good job. It isn't just big. The finishing is perfect, too.

Almost everything was ready save two.

"Master Lloyd," said Javier with a frown, as Lloyd was getting ready to actually evacuate the citizens. "What happened to reinforcements?"

"Reinforcements?"

"Yeah," Javier continued with a look of doubt in his eyes. "You sent out missives requesting reinforcements from here and there."

"I did."

In fact, Lloyd had requested aid from Queen Magentano, Cremo, Namaran, the Sultanate, orc, and elf tribes, the mermaid kingdom, and the Centauri tribe in the Great Plains. He had pretty much sent out missives to every faction that he could enlist the help of.

“That’s why I’m concerned. It’s been almost three months since we requested for aid, but nobody has responded, let alone come.”

“They have their reasons.”

“Reasons?”

“Of course they do. Please don’t tell me they haven’t responded because I am that much hated by them.”

“...”

“Dude.”

“My apologies.”

“Ugh, forget it. Anyhow, it’s a problem if they come too early.”

“What do you mean?”

“Food.”

“Huh?” Replied Javier with a confused look.

“Think about it. Let’s say Her Majesty dispatched a few thousand soldiers. None of those guys would be skinny or fragile. They would be healthy, and eat a lot of food. Imagine how much food we would waste per day.”

“...”

“Not to mention the orcs, mermaids, and centauri. Think of the expenses that we would incur by trying to keep them moralized with proper meals.”

“...”

“So I specifically requested on the bottom of the missives to time their arrivals to two months after receiving the missives.”

“I see.”

“Speaking of the devil.”

“Wait. So that noise is...”

“Most likely.”

Lloyd shrugged his shoulders as he looked up in the sky. Javier lifted his head too and beheld the small silhouettes that made whooshing sounds through the air, shortly before crash landing in the front yard of the lord’s mansion.

Thwoosh! Thump! Crush!

Muscular creatures with sharp dorsal fins landed on the ground like projectiles from a trebuchet, creating a dust storm in the vicinity from the impact on the ground. By the time it subsided, somebody spoke up.

“Whew. Lloyd Frontera. Is it true that we could meet creatures that are as strong as us here?” The mermaid queen showed a characteristically baleful, yet gracious smile through the dust in the air.

That was the first group of reinforcements that Lloyd had been waiting for.

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Chapter 390: Calm Before the Storm (2)

“Whew. Lloyd Frontera. Is it true that we could meet creatures that are as strong as us here?”

The fearsome grin that showed amidst the dust storm reminded Lloyd how much of a killer smile the mermaid queen possessed; it was literally terrifying.

Look at all those muscles. Even her cheeks are so big.

Lloyd inadvertently flinched at the thought of intense exercise that would have made even the cheek muscles bulge out. But on the outside, he maintained a welcoming smile nonetheless.

“Haha. Ha. Thank you so much for agreeing to help us.”

“No need. I kind of wanted to see if the Jewel of Truth had been constructed to perfection, anyways.”

“I see.”

“That’s why I brought my best warriors with me.”

The mermaid queen glanced behind her quickly, pointing at the front yard of the lord’s mansion. It was like a bodybuilding contest, full of half-fish warriors that seemed powerful. And that wasn’t all; more warriors fell from the sky even as Lloyd stared at flexing muscles. Some fell on the front yard, some in the backyard, and others in the entrance to the property. It was like a trebuchet bombardment.

“Uh, well, I didn’t expect these many warriors to help me out.”

“Quite the contrary. I hand-picked only a thousand.”

“I see... But how did you... come all the way here?”

“You saw it. We jumped.”

“Jumped...?”

“Yeah,” replied the mermaid queen, with an even deadlier smile on her muscular face. “We are a people that swim through the oceans and seas, from the depths to crashing waves during tornadoes, with powerful kicks alone. We take pride in our raw strength to push and stomp on things with our tailfin. We found the lack of water pressure a bit strange in the beginning when we got out, but soon realized stomping on the ground made it much easier for us to move a longer distance each time.”

“O-oh. That’s amazing.”

“It is indeed. A refreshingly new experience, it was. Ascending by about a thousand feet in the air with one stomp on the ground made me feel so good.”

“Wh-what about landing?”

“You saw it with your eyes,” said the mermaid queen, shrugging her broad shoulders. “We land with our upper body because it’s more convenient that way. We apply an immense amount of pressure on our upper body muscles from the wrist and forearms to the biceps, triceps, shoulders, back, and abs. It was a whole-body workout because we would go back to our lower body to jump up again.”

“So you basically exercised your way here.”

“Of course we did. We got out of the water on the nearest beach around here and passed by a few human settlements. The villagers were fortunately extremely kind. They rushed to our aid when we asked in which direction the Frontera Estate was.”

“...The roughest criminals would become nice and kind in your mighty, muscular presence.”

“Huh? What do you mean?”

“N-never mind. I am truly grateful that you came. Everyone, please come this way so I can show you to your rooms.”

Lloyd barely managed to contain his bitter chuckle, as he could see what kind of events would have transpired as the mermaids and men found their way to Frontera Estate. The fear innocent villagers would have felt was obvious.

I would have seen the doctor after this from the shock if I was one of them. Whew.

Lloyd guided one thousand mermaid warriors to the honeybee apartment complex, shortly before escorting the mermaid queen and introduced her to Count Frontera. To the estate developer’s relief, the count did not faint upon the sight.

Other reinforcements followed. Next to show up was the orc tribe alliance.

Shriek! “Frontera Estate is a brother of Sand and Steel Tribe! Sand and Steel Tribe is a member of the orc alliance! Brother of a member is out brother! Help we, our friend!” *Shriek!*

“Help we, our friend!” *Shriek!*

“Help we, our brother!” *Shriek!*

“Help we, our girlfriend!” *Shriek!*

“...There’s a spy among us!” *Shriek!*

Thirty thousand orc warriors rushed to the estate, flexing their muscles as they filled the wide, paved road. Grand chieftain Krash of the orc alliance visited the mansion on behalf of all orcs, and Arosh was excited to see him.

“Uncle Krash!” *Shriek!*

“My nephew!” *Shriek!*

Bam! The high-five between two muscular and strong orcs made a sound so explosive that people thought someone was playing the drums. But nothing out of the ordinary took place as the grand chieftain was straightforward and genuinely polite, despite the rough nature. However, flares sparked between the two as soon as the grand chieftain saw the mermaid queen.

Her back muscles are no joke. Shriek!

Look at the sheer size of the torso. He definitely has amazing core muscles.

They exchanged looks that suggested how eager they were to face one another in completion of strengths like arm-wrestling or dead-lifting should they have an opportunity.

Other reinforcements included 300 elf archers from the Everglow Woods, and they were extremely quiet and subtle as they arrived unlike the previous two. Next were 500 sprinters from the centauri tribe in the Great Plains, followed by one battalion of artillerymen from the Cremo Estate, two companies of mountain pikemen from the Namaran Estate, a company of high-tier Mamluk cavalry deployed by the Sultan from the east, and lastly, 10,000 royal soldiers under the direct command of Queen Alicia Termina Magentano from the west.

“...Huh?”

Lloyd rubbed his eyes in disbelief at the sight of an unexpected individual at the head of the royal army.

What the... Why is Her Majesty here...?

It was absolutely unexpected and astonishing, and the queen perhaps read Lloyd’s thoughts; she was giving a blatant look of contempt to Lloyd.

“It’s been a while, Lloyd Frontera.”

“I, Lloyd Frontera, the servant of the rightful ruler of these lands, am honored to see you again, Your Majesty.”

“Really?”

“I am truly awe-struck.”

“Hmm. You seem rather perplexed instead.”

“Not at all, Your Majesty.”

“And you’d dare to speak a blatant lie now?”

“Not at all, Your Majesty. I would never.”

“Then why did you look so surprised the moment you saw me?”

“Out of my audacious concerns and worries about you, Your Majesty.”

“Concerns and worries? About me? From you?”

“That is correct,” said Lloyd with buttery lips, surprising the queen in return. “As I have stated in the missive to humbly request reinforcements, the invasion by the hell’s army isn’t going to be an easy battle.”

“I suppose so. It will most likely be a gruesome one.”

“That is why I was worried and concerned.”

“No way.”

“Yes way, Your Majesty.”

“How dare you worry about my safety.”

“Please forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“Tsk, tsk,” said the queen, empathetically staring at the estate developer. “Worries and concerns by someone that cannot even hold his own in a sparring match against me. I don’t know what I’m supposed to make of that.”

“Please consider this to have stemmed from my unending loyalty towards my only liege, Your Majesty.”

“Loyalty? Is that really it?”

“Huh?”

“Hmm.”

Gulp. Lloyd made eye contact with the queen and saw the element of dissatisfaction in her eyes. He began to sweat uncomfortably.

Why are you looking at me like the predator trying to hunt down the prey...?

It sent unexpected chills down his spine, but the estate developer quickly shook the fear off and added.

“It will be an unprecedentedly tough battle. Should any harm befall you, Your Majesty, I’m just afraid of the repercussions that would follow--“

“You’re afraid of the consequences and the responsibilities you’d have to bear.”

“I am, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd was being honest. Even as he was requesting aid from the royal court, he really did not wish to see the queen lead the army herself to show up here.

I’ll be toast if something terrible happens to the queen. I don’t want that.

Of course, the queen was a mighty warrior herself, and far superior in might to Lloyd. But the enemy army consisted of 500 hell’s knights, each of whom was more powerful than the swordmaster queen herself. Despite Lloyd’s concerns about her safety, however, the queen seemed to think differently.

“Lloyd Frontera. This estate is a part of the territories I rightfully own.”

“That is true, and I am aware, Your Majesty.”

“Are you telling me to sit back and watch from the side, when my territory is being invaded?”

“...”

“If you honestly thought I would have, I am truly disappointed.”

“Please forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“That sounds like a more genuine apology.”

“It is, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd internally felt awkward as he bowed. He understood that he couldn’t oppose the queen’s wish if she wanted to partake in the battle.

It’s not like I could tell her to return to the royal capital without her army. I’ll just have to make sure she doesn’t get hurt.

While her presence was definitely going to help in terms of slaying enemies, Lloyd had to ensure her safety during battle. As Lloyd tried to incorporate this factor into his strategy, he heard the footsteps of two people running towards the scene. It was Count and Countess Frontera, rushing to greet Her Majesty at the head of the royal army.

“Marbella Frontera, wife of Arcos Frontera, at your service, Your Majesty.”

They had obviously sprinted here immediately upon hearing the news, evidenced by the urgency in their movement as they prostrated without trying to fix their unkempt hair or outfit, not to mention the unexpected surprise and tension from the shock.

Come to think of it, it’s their first time seeing the queen.

Lloyd realized how astonished they must have been by the visit of the queen, who graciously greeted them with a satisfactory smile on her face.

“It’s a pleasure to finally meet you two. I’ve heard so many good things about you from your son, Lloyd Frontera.”

“...Huh?”

“He was so proud of you two for being the best lords and parents in the entire world.”

“Oh...”

“And I think he had a reason to be, now that I see you with my own eyes. That is why I consider this meeting to be a delightful one.”

“Y-you have our sincerest gratitude, Your Majesty!”

The count and the countess appeared genuinely touched as they prostrated again to pay respect to their liege. The queen’s smile became more apparent, as she took a quick glance at Lloyd.

Wait. That’s the look of someone asking me if she did a good job.

Lloyd gulped nervously, contemplating whether he was supposed to nod in agreement. But the look in the queen’s sparkly eyes was so inviting, that Lloyd couldn’t help but acknowledge it anxiously. It seemed that Queen Magentano was truly delighted by the good first impression she gave and received in this encounter. Lloyd subtly nodded, making the queen even more satisfied.

It somehow felt like that awkward moment when a man would introduce his girlfriend to his parents for the first time. Lloyd was convinced that he wasn’t just having outrageous thoughts.

This is bad. Really bad.

Terrible feelings struck his gut. Lloyd’s lifelong wish was to find a rather ordinary woman to fall in love with, before getting married and having kids with her to lead an unremarkable family life. This was the extent of the luxury he had always dreamed of, not the frantic romance with the mightiest queen in the entire continent.

I can see and feel it. I can sense it. This isn’t good.

Lloyd could see himself in the queen's pockets, like a scaredy cat in the presence of a ferocious lioness. But the queen and Lloyd's parents were engaging in pleasant conversations despite what Lloyd was feeling. They appeared genuinely delighted; Lloyd wondered if he had ever seen that side of the queen, and the smile on her face somehow made the intense heat of the mid-summer day feel absolutely refreshing...

...Snap out of it, dude!

Lloyd shook his head fiercely, suppressing the strange feeling that was trying to overtake him. He convinced himself that this wasn't the time to embrace anything mellow, as the huge obstacle was literally right around the corner. He cooled himself down with such thoughts and made the final preparation before the battle kicked off; it was to evacuate the citizens of Frontera Estate and Lacona Barony. Thanks to the cooperative dragon Solitas's help, all regular citizens were mass-teleported into his lair.

Five more days passed, and the sun rose to embark on the morning of the fateful day. Lloyd stepped outside and embraced the sunlight, heading towards the Jewel of Truth located in the northern part of the estate but making it seem like a normal hike. The purpose was clear.

Let's verify what outcome all the efforts I made thus far would bring about.

He wanted to see if the preparations were adequate if he was going to survive, or if there was something else he needed to do. He had wished to confirm it again prior to the battle, but couldn't use the ending spoiler.

I don't have enough CP.

Lloyd had resorted to ending spoilers several times leading up to this point to prepare for the grand fight and was actually running low. He thought he had accumulated enough, but failed to spend it wisely out of anxiety.

But I still have the Jewel of Truth. I must not lose focus.

Lloyd dived into the water, brushing unnecessary thoughts aside. He placed his hands on the altar, activated the mana heart, and operated the circle to

trigger the glow more than 200 feet underwater.

Zing! The Jewel of Truth approached Lloyd's consciousness, through every sense he possessed.

[You, who wish to obtain a truthful answer from the Jewel of Truth. You must reveal a secret about yourself, that only you are aware of, to this world in exchange for the truth you seek.]

The voice and the process were as expected. Lloyd already knew what response he was going to give.

The truth about me that I'm going to reveal this time is...

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Chapter 391: Calm Before the Storm (3)

“You’re here. Have a seat, you don’t want the food to get cold.”

“Yeah.”

Lloyd sat on the chair and dragged his seat towards the table, on which a meal more humble than usual welcomed him. The countess herself prepared the meal for the first time in a while, as all maidservants evacuated the estate. Lloyd’s parents smiled all the way as their son glanced back at them slightly uncomfortably. He appreciated them, but certainly thought he did not deserve to be on the receiving end of such care and affection; Lloyd felt the need to change the subject.]

“What about Her Majesty?”

“Her Majesty will have a meal separately.”

“Separately?”

“She showed us kindness by allowing the three of us to spend some time together, since this is the last dinner before a grand battle.”

“Oh...”

Lloyd realized it was indeed his last supper before the epic fight, as Count Frontera added.

“She also said she did not want to see her trusted vassal and his family suffer from digestion problems. That’s why I wanted to ask if Her Majesty has... well... a peculiar habit during meals?”

“Not at all.”

“Really?”

“Her mealtime etiquette is as elegant and excellent as you could expect. Her manner of speech may appear tenacious at times, but it’s actually fitting

considering her authority. She actually listens to her vassals and tries to understand how they feel.”

“I see. So Her Majesty was being genuinely kind.”

“Most likely. Her Majesty is like that.”

“What do you mean?”

“She appears tough on the surface, but is actually very sweet.”

“I see. That’s what I find even stranger.”

“Huh?” Lloyd responded confusedly as the count continued.

“According to others that have had an audience with Her Majesty or spent time by her side, the queen is fair and just, yet ruthless and cold. That’s what I heard from many different people.”

“Uh, well...”

“I take it that you got to see the side that others weren’t able to?”

“I suppose so...?”

Lloyd was flustered by the unanticipated flow of the conversation. Even the looks his parents gave him throughout made him feel uncomfortable.

“The time you spent by her side must have been very meaningful.”

“Uh, well, I guess...”

“We heard about it, too.”

“Heard?”

“That you spent two months with Her Majesty alone--

“Thank you for the meal!”

Lloyd quickly started eating from the fear that he'd have digestive problems anyway even without the presence of the queen. But the smile on his parents' faces did not depart.

"It's really okay. We are ready to accept anything."

"...Huh?"

"Although it's far from the ordinary relationship we were expecting you to be in, sometimes things like this happen."

"...What?"

"I suppose you wouldn't be a victim of domestic abuse, since you're a swordmaster yourself, right?"

Lloyd realized things weren't really going well for him. He genuinely regretted having decided to spend two months with the queen, despite having stopped an unfortunate tragedy that was predestined to follow, by curing her arm. Lloyd thought he had overcome an obstacle, but it appeared he had run into another.

Ugh, I hate this kind of misunderstanding.

Lloyd did not comprehend why people would resort to making such assumptions based on only a few hints they saw. For him, it was just two months together with the queen to cure her illness. It was overwhelming. It was uncomfortable. He had to change the subject immediately to get out of the tight spot.

"But aren't you... afraid...?"

"Afraid? Of what?" The count replied.

"Tonight."

The smile on the count's face slightly subsided as Lloyd continued.

“I was actually surprised not to see you among the citizens evacuating the estate. This place might be razed to ashes by the sunrise tomorrow morning. It will be dangerous.”

That was Lloyd’s honest thought. In fact, he had been astonished to see them outside of the teleportation seal, letting out chuckles before returning to the mansion as though their presences were required here.

“It isn’t too late now. I can reach out to the dragon if you want to flee to his lair.”

“Hmm.”

“The citizens over there would love you two to be there with them since they need a leader to rely on in a crisis like this.”

Lloyd shared his thoughts with the count, who responded by lifting his head slowly.

“I beg to differ, Lloyd.”

“Huh?”

“Think about it. What title do I hold in this estate?”

“You’re the lord of--“

“Right. I am the lord of this estate.”

“But...”

“I understand how you feel, and that’s enough for us. As the lord of this estate and holder of the authority to govern this land as per Her Majesty’s command, I am bound by oath to protect the citizens and their homes. I cannot evacuate the property just because everyone is doing the same in the face of a disaster,” said the count, in a more serious voice than ever. “Especially in the absence of the citizens. Somebody must be here to keep their homes safe so they have a place to return after the battle. That is my

duty and responsibility as a nobleman and the lord of the estate, even if it is inefficient.”

“But father--“

“I know what you’re trying to say, Lloyd. To tell you the truth, your mother and I are scared too. But we still decided to remain and fulfill our duties despite all that. I hope you can respect that.”

“...Yeah.”

Lloyd had no choice but to agree this time after seeing the resolute stance his parents displayed, even though he still had thousands of counterarguments to make. Lloyd could only make them promise him one thing.

“Just make sure to lock up the master bedroom tightly tonight.”

“I was hoping to partake in the battle.”

“No.”

“But I had my sword and armor polished for this occasion.”

“No.”

“You’re being adamant.”

“Because I have to be,” Lloyd insisted.

He had to be. Mayhem was going to break out in a few hours of time, and losing his parents was the last thing he wanted. Perhaps that was why he got a sudden impulse to reveal everything.

Is this the right time to tell them?

The real Lloyd Frontera, who had been an absolute failure of a man, was no more. He wondered if this would be the last chance to share what fate their real son went through, and what caused all of this to happen.

It probably is.

The hell's gate was about to open. According to the answer by the Jewel of Truth before, what he had to do was clear.

I should.

He had made this promise with Lloyd. He had strengthened his resolve plenty of times. He had to break the news even if it would cause them to grieve and despise him. It was now or never.

"Actually, there's something I need to tell you."

Lloyd took a deep breath. His heart pounded extremely fast and his hands trembled like a leaf.

"I am..."

But before he could finish, Count Frontera interrupted him.

"Hold on, Lloyd."

"...Huh?"

"I think I know what you're trying to say, but can it wait until the battle is over?"

"Huh?!"

"It's just a bit... awkward to hear it from your own lips. Your mother and I know better than anyone else just how much you love and care for us. I just feel like it's a red flag suggesting a tragic ending if you tell us that now. So... please say it after we both survive tonight."

"Well, uh, I..."

"Please, Lloyd. I'm asking you a favor."

"..."

Lloyd became speechless at the benevolent glance by the count and the countess. He simply nodded because he was in no circumstance to bring it up now.

“I understand.”

“Thank you.”

The two smiled in relief. Lloyd wondered if that was how they were giving their son an excuse to hold off on carrying out an uncomfortable duty and focus on the imminent battle instead.

“...Okay. Just make sure you stay safe.”

After the meal was over, he stepped out of the mansion and embraced the red sky in the dusk of an early summer. He walked and tried to shake off the lingering fear and other complex emotions until someone interrupted him.

“I’m not sure what to make of the secret that you actually enjoyed causing strife between two parties behind the scenes at Summoner’s Rift.”

A familiar voice graced Lloyd’s ears before a certain someone joined him on the stroll so naturally and nonchalantly, like a veteran driver changing lanes without breaking a sweat. Lloyd took a glance and noticed Javier walking side by side with him, shrugging his shoulders.

“I’m still confused by the secret that was revealed when you used the Jewel of Truth a moment ago.”

“There’s nothing else to it.”

“I’m not confused by the fact that you enjoyed causing strife between people. I get that.”

“Then?”

“What is this Summoner’s Valley?”

“A living hell, in which people cry out for help, bash on trolls, and swear at each other’s mothers.”

“...And you’ve been to a place like that discreetly?”

“Yeah.”

It was true. In fact, Suho used to skip classes and go to the internet cafe to visit this place without telling his parents. Nothing he said in that statement was false.

“But aren’t you afraid?” Lloyd asked, changing the subject.

“Afraid of what?”

“You know. Of later.”

“The hell’s army?”

“Yeah,” replied Lloyd with a nod. “Because I actually am scared.”

“So am I.”

“I knew it.”

“Yeah.”

“That’s the only reason I’m saying this,” said Lloyd. It was a strange day as the estate developer felt the need to share things he wouldn’t have under normal circumstances. Perhaps it was because of what he had seen through the Jewel of Truth. “Thank you for everything you’ve done.”

But today was the only day he had a chance to, and the only day in which people wouldn’t give him dirty looks for it.

“I couldn’t have gotten this far or accomplished anything without you. Even though you were sometimes... I mean always grumbling and complaining, I never disliked that side of you once.”

Javier silently listened as Lloyd continued.

“I appreciate it. I’m asking for your help yet again tonight, but just make sure you don’t stretch yourself and get hurt.”

That was Lloyd’s honest thought. He hadn’t had a chance to share this with Javier, and felt like he would never have an opportunity after the battle. Lloyd took time to share his true feelings with the grandmaster that stood by his side since he first came to this world because he was going to regret it if he didn’t. But the reply was absolutely unexpected.

“Hmm. I heard people do things that are out of character when death is imminent.”

“...”

“This must be a terrible sign to see the touchy side of you that you wouldn’t otherwise show.”

“...Dude.”

“I’m listening.”

“Can’t you feel my honest intentions?”

“No.”

“...”

“But I felt something else,” added Javier with a smirk on his face.

“What.”

“Vigilance within me, warning me against an unpleasant surprise.”

“What?”

“I think my experience is telling me to beware of the intent to exploit me with sugar-coated words again.”

“What am I, a scumbag boss?”

“...”

“Please don’t tell me you really thought I was.”

“Something like that.”

“...”

“I have something to say, too, Master Lloyd.”

“What.”

“I wanted to express my gratitude, too.”

“I won’t fall for it.”

“That’s just how I feel.”

“I’m not buying it.”

“I don’t think Frontera Estate and the citizens here would be as prosperous and well off without you. I truly appreciate everything you’ve done, and admire you for not boasting about your accomplishments once.”

“Stop messing with me.”

“So I made the decision to serve you more faithfully as a knight in your service, if we get to see the sun tomorrow morning.”

“Stop. You don’t have to raise a red flag on a day like this.”

“What do you mean by red flag?”

“You wouldn’t get it. Ugh, do I have to perform a ritual to get rid of the evil spirit now?”

“...”

“Let’s head back. It’s time.”

“As you wish.”

Time to reminisce about the past was over, and Lloyd took Javier and headed back to the estate. It really was time.

They’re supposed to invade at midnight.

The hell’s gate was about to open, and hundreds of hell’s knights followed by thousands of demons, not to mention the king of hell, were going to flood in. Physical preparations had been made, and they needed to be mentally ready.

***

A few hours passed, and the sky was no longer red. Darkness hovered over the estate as the constellation of the prisoner lit the night sky. The defenders of the estate silently waited for midnight in their positions assigned by Lloyd. Some were hiding behind the shrubs, and some stood on the roof of the apartment complex, all awaiting the moment nervously. The tension and feelings of insecurity before the battle were apparent, but no one panicked because they had made thorough preparations according to the plan by Lloyd Frontera, who was known for his meticulousness. There was not a shred of doubt in their heads that the battle would go as expected as proven time and again.

The full moon lit up the night sky, and there was a sudden change in the atmosphere.

Bzzzzzzzt. Red flashes of lightning fell from the night sky, making thunderous roars and ominous flapping noises. The moon turned red, and the hell’s gate opened.

Bzzt! The nefarious ring spewed out the intense heat from hell about 300 feet above the ground, shortly before creatures that were even more forbidding showed themselves in the midst of darkness, glaring through their glowing eyes. The first unit of hell’s knights was here.

Clink! Clink! The plate armors clashed, as the hell's knights rode the hell's steeds and began breathing the air in the human realm. They all harbored the ill will to bring chaos and despair to this place as they jumped down from the gate and jumped down to the ground one by one. Each member of the Frontera Alliance saw the frightening sight and clenched his or her fist in confidence.

It worked!

The first hell's knight dove straight into the pool of holy water instead of the ground as it had expected. The holy water pool party, which no hell's knight even imagined in its wildest dreams had only just begun.

Splash!

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Chapter 392: Battle of Holy Water (1)

“Death to Lloyd Frontera!”

“Destruction to Frontera Estate!”

“Demise to Suho Kim!”

The hell’s knights let out battle cries robustly in the fiery hell on the other side of the hell’s gate, while riding on the back of hell’s steeds that were more ferocious than ogres. They were overrun with the excitement of showering themselves in the blood of humans and creatures in the humanly realm. It was likewise for the commander, Sir Kalidus of the Second Corp of hell’s army.

Today is the day we welcome a new commander-in-chief.

He recalled the plan by his liege, king of hell, to bring the human Suho Kim in under his wings to have him work as commander in chief overseeing the day-to-day operation of the entire underworld. He had initially dared to oppose the idea in the beginning, as he couldn’t imagine serving a human as a higher-ranking officer.

But so be it.

If that was what his liege, the supreme ruler of the underworld, wished, he could only accept the decision graciously as he was only a sword to be swung in the hands of his master.

Shring. Clink!

Hell’s knight Sir Kalidus drew both of his darkened swords crafted with demon bones and released sinister energy in the dead of night. He strengthened his resolve to take the enemy’s life himself, if he was going to serve a human as a higher-ranking officer. He was determined to behead the human with his own sword and place his head on the pike. That was going to be his way of welcoming the new commander-in-chief. With this resolute

mindset embedded in his bones, Sir Kalidus followed the steps of the first unit of hell's knights and into the portal of hell's gate.

Whoosh!

The air immediately changed as soon as he passed through the portal. The refreshingly disturbing scent of the fiery hell was no more, and the detestably clear air surrounded him.

Tsk, tsk. What a horrid place.

Sir Kalidus jumped down from hell's gate, allowing the gravity of a strange realm to pull him down to the ground approximately 300 feet down. He took a quick glance at the surroundings as he fell.

I don't see anybody, as expected. They must be clueless.

That had to be, since all this was planned in the underworld; there was no way mere humans in this terrible realm could have found out about it.

Although our liege hasn't had a chance to monitor what was going on in the human realm because he had to incarnate himself in the lich's body.

But that wasn't going to cause any change and all humans in this estate were going to die tonight.

"By my hands!"

Sir Kalidus landed on the ground with a heinous shout, or so he thought. He fell straight into the deep, cold water awaiting him.

Splash!

"What?!"

Caught off guard by the unexpected presence of water underneath, Sir Kalidus expressed his displeasure.

Ugh. The hell's gate must have opened above the river or something.

It appeared that way, but it did not matter to the hell's knight because all he had to do was swim out of the river. Hell's knights weren't going to drown anyway.

It's inconvenient, but whatever.

Sizzle!

That was when extreme heat overwhelmed his body, simultaneously as he shivered from the mysterious sensation that felt as if he had just been struck by lightning or crushed by a huge boulder. The excruciating pain mercilessly tortured him.

"Ugh... Argh!"

Sir Kalidus inadvertently twitched in agony as each of his bones felt extreme discomfort. Sir Kalidus finally realized he hadn't fallen into an ordinary body of water.

I-is this holy water?!

Sizzle!

Holy water wreaked absolute havoc on Sir Kalidus's body, giving him a painful seizure. It wasn't an unremarkable holy water either; it was a high-grade one, made from the tears of the high-ranking angel of thrones. Other hell's knights had fallen and fell in the pool of holy water and suffered the same agony as they struggled like fish out of water.

And the number of victims grew exponentially. Sir Kalidus barely managed to contain the pain and shouted out.

"There's a pool of holy water right here! Aaaaack!"

The cry filled the skies and reached the hell's gate, warning the hell's knight that was just passing through the portal. He barely stopped and checked the ground saw the holy water, and passed the message onto his comrades-in-arms.

“There’s a pond of holy water beneath the gate, so jump across when you leave the gate!”

The hell’s knights began to perform long jumps as they left through the portal, drawing a high arch in the air before landing. However, another pool of holy water awaited them there as well.

Splash! Splash!

“Aaaahhhh!”

Hell’s knights cried out in pain and agony as they were showered with holy water. That wasn’t the end of the torture, however, as a melody even more terrifying and peculiar than the holy water itself banged their eardrums while the hell’s knights suffered.

“Row! Row! Row your boat! Gently down the stream!”

“...Urgh.”

“Merrily! Merrily! Merrily! Merrily! Life is but a dream!”

Splash! Splash!

The abysmal melody felt like a genuine attempt at a song by a naturally horrid singer, and that was what made it worse for the listeners of the jam. Strange off-beat recitations accompanied by egregious vibration.

“Row! Row! Row your boat! Gently down the stream! Merrily! Merrily! Merrily! Merrily! Life is but a dream! Da-dun!”

Splash!

Hell’s knights helplessly continued to jump into the pool of holy water like lemmings jumping off the cliff, realizing something in the process.

“It’s Suho Kim!”

“That bastard must be near!”

“He has to be here somewhere!”

The eyes of hell’s knights glowed as they suffered immense torment inside the holy water. They finally strengthened their resolve to get up.

“Our target... must be near.”

“I will kill him myself!”

The first target to be eliminated during this war was Suho Kim, who was presumably in the vicinity. Each of the hell’s knights burned with the passion to make the greatest contribution to tonight’s inevitable victory by beheading the detestable human being, before being acknowledged as the legendary hell’s knight honored by the king of hell himself, to cause the entire underworld to bow before it. They weren’t willing to share the glory with their comrades-in-arms.

“Ugh...!”

Commander Sir Kalidus of the Second Corps of hell’s army stopped struggling and fell to the bottom of the water, stomped on the ground, and rapidly resurfaced. He finally got himself out of the water and rolled on the soil.

“Huff, huff... Ugh...”

The pain from bathing in holy water was only temporary.

I will not give in!

Only his outer bones had been soaked, and the hell’s knight was convinced he could endure the pain and still put up a fight.

“Aaaaargh!!”

Sir Kalidus let out a sharp cry as he leaned on the two swords he had placed on the ground, looking around viciously with the intent to spot the human that was singing a horrid song somewhere in the vicinity.

“Suho Kim!”

A part of his armor turned into the hell’s steed as soon as he shouted. Sir Kalidus got on the horse and charged toward Lloyd, followed by other hell’s knights that had managed to escape the body of holy water, with strong animosity against the man who was going to offer the most valuable spoil of war. Lloyd saw the fearsome knights fiercely charging towards him and grinned satisfactorily.

“Perfect.”

He successfully drew their attention, just as he had planned and expected.

“Isn’t that right, Your Majesty?”

“...”

“Your Majesty?”

Queen Alicia finally removed her fingers that had been plugging her ears only after confirming Lloyd had stopped singing.

“...Are you done singing?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“What a relief. I was seriously contemplating if I had to get rid of my eardrums entirely.”

“...”

“Are we to move according to the tactic now?” The queen asked.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

The start was certainly good. Lloyd had the workers construct a few large-scale pools of holy water underneath the spot where the hell’s gate was going to open, with the intent to deliver some damage to the first unit of hell’s knights. It had gone according to plan.

And it definitely made them upset.

Hell's knights were too strong to drown in holy water, nor would they sustain severe injuries. The only way to effectively wear them down was to break their bones first.

So the holy water soaks their bone marrows and cartilage as well.

Otherwise, hell's knights had to be bathed within for an hour or two in order for human fighters to slay them.

But I can't do that with just pools of holy water.

These ponds weren't intended to drown them, but to give them a taste of it. Lloyd knew he had to lure them into a more carefully laid trap.

"Alright, we gotta run now. Okay?"

"Ppodong!"

Ppodong robustly lifted its thumb up in response. Lloyd gently petted the beast in the back of its neck.

"Good. You'll run as much as you want today."

Lloyd then turned his head towards the queen and spoke again.

"Your Majesty?"

"I am ready. Begin."

The queen, who was riding on the cushiony back of Ppodong alongside Lloyd, had already drawn her sword and been letting out a fearsome vibe. She was basically making a statement that she was prepared for battle, with her entire body. Lloyd saw that and lightly slapped the back of Ppodong's neck.

"Let's go, Ppodong!"

“Ppodong!”

The colossal hamster’s plump feet stomped on the ground, as the beast accelerated like a missile.

Whoooooosh! Its zero-back was certainly within three seconds. Lloyd saw the scenery appear blurry in an instant, as the wind slammed him in his forehead, cheeks, and then his entire body. But Lloyd encouraged Ppodong even further.

“Faster! Quicker!”

Hell’s knights on the back of hell’s steeds were chasing after him at full speed, with the vicious-looking one wielding two swords glaring at Lloyd in the front.

“Your Majesty!” Lloyd shouted out, and Queen Alicia moved towards Ppodong’s plump buttocks.

Zing.

As soon as the queen pointed her sword towards the back, her weapon was shrouded in the vividly blue aura that stretched nearly twenty feet in length.

“Hraah!”

Queen Alicia swung her sword horizontally with a shout, causing the twenty-foot aura to slash across the trail. Commander Sir Kalidus of the Second Corp of hell’s army leading the other demonic knights saw the attack and responded.

Boom! Thump! Thwoosh!

Sir Kalidus used both of his swords to block the aura attack by the queen. The impact from the clashes sent out forceful shockwaves to the surroundings, causing Sir Kalidus’s steed to stagger while Ppodong sped up from the momentum. Queen Alicia retained her stance like a superhuman creature, astounding Lloyd in the process.

Holy. The queen actually managed it.

It was a head-on clash against a mighty hell's knight while standing on the cushiony, unstable surface in Ppodong's plump butt cheeks. She did not even lose balance, let alone get pushed back or sustain damage, indicating one thing.

She's improved since she mastered the Asrahan Core Technique. Sure, the hell's knight probably is in a weakened state because of the holy water, but she's almost equally as strong.

The queen had certainly surpassed the swordmaster level. Although she wasn't a grandmaster yet, Lloyd suspected she was somewhere in between.

Amazing.

It was reassuring, but concerning at the same time. Lloyd shouted out with both thoughts in his mind.

"Your Majesty! We are almost there, so please do not overstretch yourself!"

He was genuinely worried that she might lose her composure in the heat of the moment and more actively engage the enemy.

"Ha! Says a weakling!" The queen responded ferociously.

"..."

"Think about it! How can I ever leave you alone among the enemies when you're so weak?! I am doing you a favor by stepping into the danger with you! Don't you dare worry about me!"

"Th-that's—"

"I am worried myself, because I'm not sure if it's okay to put my trust in a weakling such as yourself!"

"Weakling? But I'm a swordmaster myself, Your Majesty!"

“Except you’re a feeble, fragile little boy that can’t defeat a hell’s knight alone.”

“...”

“So shut up and be protected.”

“...”

“Answer.”

“I-I am honored...?!”

Lloyd questioned if the inability to defeat a hell’s knight in one-on-one combat made a man fragile because Javier was the only man in the entire world that wasn’t feeble by that logic.

Ugh. Hmph.

Lloyd internally grumbled and encouraged Ppodong to run faster. As soon as they got away from the central village, he looked up towards Ggoming and signaled.

Ggoming! Now! Go to Javier and deliver the message you’re supposed to!

Ggoming flew in circle once, before speeding towards the eastern mountain range. Lloyd maintained the speed towards the south, past another village and Frona River that was showing its bottom, towards Maritz Farmlands. Ppodong’s began to breathe hard.

“Ppodong... Ppodong... Huff. Huff.”

The gigantic hamster slowed down as its legs started to give up on the beast. On the other hand, the hell’s knights were still chasing after Lloyd even more tenaciously. Sir Kalidus, who had been fending off Queen Alicia’s attacks all along the ride, was burning with the greatest passion.

“How much longer do you think you can keep running away?!”

Dash!

The commander had gotten so close to Ppodong's butt. Kalidus swung his two swords toward the hamster's hind legs, but Queen Alicia unleashed her aura attacks to parry off the swing. Sir Kalidus did not rush things, however. Instead, he composedly put pressure on his prey and gradually increased the fierceness of the attack.

"Suho Kim! You've been acting so smart and clever all this time, yet you made a terrible mistake today!" Sir Kalidus shouted out with a smirk on its face.

"Mistake? What are you talking about?" Lloyd responded immediately, triggering an even more condescending reply from the hell's knight.

"Did you honestly believe you could lose us like this? And you ran away to an open field instead of going into narrower places! You've dug your own grave with this idiotic move!"

Sir Kalidus was convinced that Lloyd had screwed up by fleeing towards open plains, at which the steeds carrying the 500 hell's knights on their back were the most destructive. It was a suicide mission from the start, and Suho had made it worse. The hell's knight was disappointed and even felt pity.

"If you truly wish to make this your graveyard, stop running and get on the ground so you can die honorably as a knight! I will kill you with my own hands!"

Sir Kalidus made a proposition for the enemy to die an honorable death instead of being slashed in the back. It was out of genuine respect, but Lloyd replied with a snort.

"What? Ha. Why should I?"

"What?"

“I wasn’t running away, nor do I have the intention to make this place my grave.”

“What are you talking about?”

“I only ran here so I can obliterate you.”

“...What?”

Sir Kalidus was confused, but he took a clean look at Lloyd’s face.

He’s... grinning.

It was certain. That bastard was beaming ever so brightly, with the most satisfactory smile on his face ever. The facial expression was definitely not that of someone who was determined to embrace his death.

“Hell, yeah. It’s as if I’ve cornered a huge cockroach with a bottle of loaded Raid in my hand. Best feeling ever.”

Lloyd felt smug as he mumbled in a condescending manner.

Rumble.

And that was when a heavy rumbling of the ground accompanied by two billion liters of something began rattling the entire mountain range, inching closer by the minute.

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Chapter 393: Battle of Holy Water (2)

Rumble. The entire eastern mountain range quaked, from deep valleys and high summits to slopes and paths. Cliffs fell apart, ponds and puddles overflowed, and creeks flooded. It roared out two billion liters of noise as the Frona River nearly exploded.

Kwooooooosh!!

The Frona River flowed down from the eastern mountains and enriched the southern soil of the Frontera Estate in a clockwise pattern, providing necessary freshwater to the citizens. But it was crying out like a fierce predator about to devour the poor prey right now. It crushed and pushed the debris in the way aside, before reaching the northern part of the Maritz Farmlands at the speed of 100 miles per hour, carrying with it the crashing wave with a height of over 400 feet.

Kwoooosh!!

Commander Sir Kalidus of the Second Corp of hell's army was shaken by the sight. He had seen his share of violence in the underworld, but nothing was quite abysmal like the catastrophe that came at him.

"Wh-what kind of--"

The storm from the fierce currents reached him first even before the crashing waves did.

Kwoooosh!

Sir Kalidus faltered, as did his war steed, giving Ppodong a chance to distance itself from its chaser momentarily. That little bit of distance and time created a perfect opportunity for Lloyd to move on to the next part of the plan.

"Ggoming!" Shouted the estate developer.

“Ggoming!” Responded a creature in white silhouette, showing itself through the storm and descending rapidly.

“Ppodong,” Lloyd quickly moved around as Ggoming flew down. “Eat this.”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong took the blue sunflower seed as Lloyd stretched out the other hand backward.

“My queen, please take my hand!”

“What did you just say?”

“We don’t have enough time, so just take my hand please!”

Poof! Lloyd grabbed hold of Her Majesty’s hand urgently and picked up Ppodong, who had minimized again. Ggoming’s talons stretched out to Lloyd and the queen in the air at that moment.

“Ggoming!”

Clutch! The flying beast successfully grabbed Lloyd by his shoulders.

“Up! Up!”

“Ggoming! Ggoming!”

Ggoming flapped its wings robustly, away from the frightening 400-feet-tall wave that ferociously and destructively crashed towards the farmlands with the intent to devour everything in its wake.

Kwooooooosh!!

The top of the wave touched Lloyd’s feet, nearly sweeping the queen away with the current. Appalled, Lloyd urgently pulled her out from the water. His shoulders were massively sore.

“Ugh... Huff! Huff!”

Lloyd clasped onto her so as not to let go of her again as he looked down.

Everything was being swept away, from the hell’s knight that was fiercely chasing after them and the knights under his command to a third of the Maritz Farmlands Lloyd and the citizens worked so hard on. It was like a colony of ants being washed away by a rainstorm.

Of course. That’s two billion liters of water for you.

Lloyd recalled the incident at Vajont Dam in Italy. The landslide allegedly caused twice as much damage as that inflicted by the atomic bomb dropped in Hiroshima.

The size of the landslide was a little over 230 million square meters. And the flood I’m seeing is carrying two billion liters of water. Holy.

Lloyd was in so much awe that he couldn’t even do the math at the moment.

I just hope it doesn’t flow towards the estate.

That was the last thing he wanted, as he anxiously prayed and monitored the flow of the currents. In fact, he had designed the gigantic waterway to control the direction of the flow without overflowing.

And the northern part of the Maritz Farmlands was the perfect destination. It borders the Frona River and used to be swampland, ideal for controlling the crashing waters, not to mention no one resides in this area because it consists of fields.

Repairing the damages in this area was going to be way less challenging as compared to residences.

I think it’s going as planned.

Lloyd internally shouted out in excitement as he got on Ggoming and gently tapped the queen in the back, who was still coughing intensely from the incident. The immense flood that began from Lake Kapua was being

controlled just as he had intended, sweeping only through a third of the Maritz Farmland and touching nothing else.

The hell's knights were being destroyed by the crashing waves that carried an extraordinary type of water. Lloyd looked down towards the scene of the catastrophe and shouted out.

"How did you like the fierce current of the holy water?!"

A massively muscular upper body appeared from the torrential currents all of a sudden. The mightiest aquatic creature was not being swept away by the disastrous flood and was even swimming against the flow. It was the mermaid queen.

"I think this is awesome! Even though the water is a bit murky, it feels more exhilarating than riding the waves in the ocean during a thunderstorm! And the water tastes amazing!"

"Of course it does! That's holy water!"

"Great! Thanks for an opportunity like this! I appreciate it!"

"Glad to hear," shouted out Lloyd robustly. "Hope you keep enjoying it!"

The mermaid queen dove back underwater after hearing the reply and glanced at five hundred hell's knights, helplessly waving around their limbs against the overwhelming currents of holy water. Those who were hit directly by the crashing waves had broken their bones, and even those who hid themselves behind ditches had sustained significant injuries. They were all writhing in pain, being swept away here and there. Valiant mermaids and mermen actively and robustly swam through the water and appeared one by one.

"My faithful warriors!" The mermaid queen shouted out solemnly and majestically, grabbing the warriors' attention. "Answer me. What do I despise the most?"

"Water pollution, and doing nothing about it!"

“Then what do you think we must do at the moment?”

“We must get rid of the filthy contaminants!”

“Precise what are those?”

“Those bastards!” The mermaid and merman warriors ferociously glared at the hell’s knights.

“Well, then. Attack!!” Commanded the queen.

“Hraaaaaaah!”

Mermaids and mermen flexed their muscles as they charged underwater towards the hell’s knights. Aquatic creatures with monstrous strength and agility underwater jumped on the evil soldiers that were flapping around like plastic bags out in the ocean.

“Urgh...!”

From Sir Kalidus of the Second Corps to the hell’s knights under his command, none of them could withstand this attack. The impact from the flood of holy water was overwhelming on its own, having soaked the bone marrows of the knights after fracturing them, but unexpected enemies were rubbing salt in the wounds.

Stomp!

A colossal foot covered in red scales stomped on Sir Kalidus, whose bones were all fractured and weakened. The damage was too tremendous for the knight to withstand. After stepping on Sir Kalidus, the young dragon Solitas rubbed his heel against the bottom of the river.

Crush!

Sir Kalidus was no more, as his body was shredded to pieces and swept away by the currents.

“One down,” said Solitas with a smirk on his face, putting his thumbs up towards Lloyd with a hopeful expectation in his mind.

It’ll go well since I decided to help out. And if he survives... I’ll get to go on a blind date!

The red dragon was burning with the passion to triumph over the enemies, as he continued to stomp on other hell’s knights. Mermaid and merman warriors endeavored to hunt down the foes, pulling those who were trying to escape back into the water. They surrounded each knight in groups and ganged up on it shamelessly.

Hell’s knights did not remain so helpless, despite the weakened state they were in. Being superior to even swordmasters, they resisted the attack even though they were soaked in holy water. But they still couldn’t flee from the crashing currents of holy water. Lloyd monitored from above and clenched his fist.

Good. The first part is a complete success.

His strategy had worked. Lloyd was convinced this battle would be remembered as the Great Battle of Holy Water and go down in history.

“We were able to stop the hell’s knights from charging further, Your Majesty. I think we should move on to the next part of the plan.”

“...Whew. Good. That’s a relief.”

“Are you alright, Your Majesty?”

“I am,” said the queen majestically and elegantly, as she shook the excess water off her hair and condescendingly glared at Lloyd. “But I must ask. What did you call me before?”

“Huh?”

“Before the wave crashed down on me, as you stretched your hand out.”

“...Uh, well, please forgive me,” said Lloyd apologetically.

“I’m listening,” insisted the queen.

“But I do not remember.”

“...”

“The situation was so dire.”

“...”

“I speak the truth, Your Majesty.”

“Really?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Ha. You’re as shameless as usual.”

“Your grace knows no bounds, Your Majesty.”

“You must return the favor then.”

“Huh?”

“I fully acknowledge that you saved my life just now. I intend to duly reward you for your act of bravery.”

“By reward--“

“I will actively look for a suitable spouse for you to court after all this is over.”

“...Pardon?”

“Because you’re an extremely shameless individual, no ordinary woman would be able to deal with your character. She’d either have to be headstrong, or skilled in swordsmanship. That is why I’m thinking of holding a contest of swords for single women.”

“Y-your Majesty?”

“Speak.”

“D-do you intend to make the winner of the contest my... bride... by any chance?”

“Of course I am. And I was thinking of participating as a contestant myself.”

“I-I beg your pardon?!”

“Is something wrong?”

“N-no. It’s just that if you were to partake in the contest, Your Majesty, you’d--“

“Win.”

“...”

“I’d better work hard on honing my skills.”

“...”

Lloyd became speechless, even though he desperately wanted to call it an absolute abuse of power, tyranny, and dictatorship.

But I’m kind of excited and glad... except what kind of marriage proposal is this threatening...?!

But Lloyd couldn’t bring it out in words, as his queen had already taken him by his hand.

“...”

It was rough, yet warm. He could feel every heartbeat that was clearly pounding faster than usual.

Ugh. There goes my dream of ordinary living.

Lloyd quickly wiped off the tear that was about to fall from his eyes at the thought of the frightening romance. But this wasn't the time to joke around, as the battle had only just begun.

"Please allow me to take us back to the hell's gate so we can carry out the next part of the strategy."

"You have my permission."

Lloyd turned Ggoming around and went back towards the north, at which the hell's gate had opened. The area was crowded by the time, not because of the demons that flooded out from the portal, however.

"Her Majesty is back!"

"Hooray!! Long live the queen!"

Ten thousand royal soldiers shouted out as their well-polished armors, helms, shields, and halberds glowed under the moonlight. Next to them were rather disorganized, yet clearly battle-ready musclemen.

"Destroy we, today!" *Shriek!*

"Crush we, today!" *Shriek!*

"Fight we, today!" *Shriek!*

"Date we, today!" *Shriek!*

"...There's a spy among us!" *Shriek!*

Thirty thousand orc warriors flexed their muscles as they shouted out like wild beasts. Elf sharpshooters were calmly readying their arrows while riding on the backs of 500 centauri, next to another 500 White Cavaliers eager to outperform their rival riders. Behind them were 1,200 Mamluk cavalry, 700 pikemen from Namaran, and 36 artillery units from Cremo, all awaiting the moment to launch their attacks. Last but not least, a large

silhouette flew this way from the eastern mountain range. It was that of the bone dragon Draggy, carrying Javier on its back and Bibeong in its arms.

Perfect. Everyone is here.

Javier, Bibeong, and the bone dragon had broken the dam at the impeccable timing, contributing greatly to the success of the holy water flood. It was thanks to them defenders of Frontera were able to rout the hell's knights.

"Your Majesty."

Lloyd glanced at Queen Alicia, signaling her to give the speech before leading them into battle.

"No. It is you that devised this strategy carefully," replied the queen, shaking her head. "It is fitting for you to act as the commander. Give the speech."

"Your grace knows no bounds, Your Majesty."

Lloyd accepted his queen's request graciously and stood firmly on Ggoming's back, speaking out to the alliance of more than 40,000 soldiers.

"This is Lloyd Frontera speaking. I won't be long. Thanks to everyone's efforts to conceal themselves as per the plan, we were able to hold the hell's knights down. Their main attacking forces are being curbed, and it is our turn to counterstrike."

Simply focusing on defense against a mighty adversary wasn't going to suffice. Besides, Lloyd wasn't the type of person to only be on the receiving end of things. That was why he lured the advancing units, crushed them, and held them down in a spot. It was his turn to fight back.

"Are you ready to invade the underworld?!"

Lloyd shouted out energetically, powered by his mana. 43,500 soldiers of the alliance responded in an even greater battle cry. The Battle of Holy Water was successful. It was time to use the momentum against the enemies and attack their base in hell.

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Chapter 394: Underworld Conquest (1)

Approximately 6,500 demons giggled in sinister excitement in front of the gate connecting to the human realm, in the extremely gut-wrenching world full of smoke and fine dust. It was the underworld.

“Ha. I can’t believe I’m actually invading the human realm. This is going to be fun.”

“I wouldn’t call it an invasion, idiot. We’re basically the cleaning crew.”

“What?”

“Am I wrong? The hell’s knights will wreak havoc in the human realm and destroy everything. We’re only going to wrap things up after them.”

“That still counts as an invasion.”

“Believe what you will, but the Frontera Estate, was it? That place is probably razed to ashes by now already. There won’t be a chicken left for us to kill on the other side of the gate.”

“Ugh.”

“So relax and keep your hopes low.”

“Still.”

“Still what?”

“It’s my first time there. I just want to have fun.”

“Well, if you put it that way, I kind of agree.”

“See?”

“Haha.”

These were some of the best demons in the entire hell, each of them matching advanced sword experts in the human realm in might.

“But how much longer do we have to stay on standby for? The enemy estate is going to be incinerated by the time we get there.”

“I don’t know. We can’t move until our lord king of hell opens his eyes.”

“True. But when is His Evil Majesty going to awaken?”

“Soon, probably.”

“Are you sure?”

“Positive,” said one of the demons with confidence. “I heard it takes about 100 or 200 days in a human’s time for his soul to settle in the lich’s body.”

“And that’s today?”

“Most likely.”

“Wow. I’m still amazed by how His Evil Majesty still took care of the day-to-day operation of the underworld despite falling into the slumber.”

“That’s why he’s our king and liege. Although he wasn’t able to monitor the human realm in the meantime because of that.”

“True.”

The two demons nodded in agreement. The king of hell indeed was astounding in that aspect, and they had not a shred of a doubt that today’s invasion was going to be an absolute success. They believed it wouldn’t even fall to the king of hell, in fact, because the Frontera Estate should already have been razed to ashes by now regardless of how well-prepared they were, and how much of a resistance they put up. Five hundred hell’s knights was just too overwhelming.

500 hell’s knights... I don’t think humans can stand against them even if they formed an alliance of the entirety of their forces.

The demons hoped for their king to open his eyes and give the command for them to cross the portal, so they could destroy everything they come in contact with in the human realm, covering themselves in red blood to have a good time.

“...Huh?”

A demon made a strange noise all of a sudden, shortly before pointing at the hell’s gate in astonishment.

“Somebody is coming!”

All 6,500 demons lifted their heads up in surprise, as the visit from the human realm was certainly an unanticipated turn of events. They hoped one of the hell’s knights was returning from the other side temporarily to give them commands, as hell’s knights were high-ranking knights of the hell’s military and could thus lead them into battle. Demons desperately waited for a fearsome and majestic hell’s knight to show itself and give the speech, stating the Frontera Estate was almost finished, but they still left some humans alone so the demons could have some fun, and that they had permission to wreak havoc against the poor humans.

Please... Please!

Demons prayed in unity from their thirst for blood. They craved atrocity and murder. Soon enough, someone came out from the portal and gave his speech.

“Hello, all.”

But it was that detestable human Lloyd. He glanced at the horde of demons and put a huge smile on his face.

“We’ve met before.”

The demons were astonished by the sight. The man riding a huge bird and flying around in circles was clearly someone most of them remembered.

Isn’t that Lloyd Frontera?

He's the guy who exploited us during the construction of the hell's railroad!

Ugh, I still remember all those overtime and day shifts.

My mother told me not to hang out with him because he was clearly more evil than demons.

But why is he here?

It was perplexing, as 500 hell's knights had definitely invaded the Frontera Estate. He wasn't supposed to show up unhurt on the other side of the hell's gate. It did not make sense.

"A-are you here to surrender?!" Shouted one of the demons in a flustered voice.

"Surrender?" Lloyd's smile turned peculiar as he responded. "Not at all. I'm here to attack."

"What?!"

"Draggy!" Lloyd shouted out instead of replying to the demons.

Creak! Creak! Creak! The bones creaked as colossal skeletal structures appeared through the gate. Several hundreds of these things floated in the air, shortly before assembling to return to their original state. The demons had seen this creature before.

"B-bone dragon!"

The bone dragon that had shown up when Lloyd took care of the magma giant was making an appearance again in the red sky of the underworld. It held the hell's gate with its two arms and placed its head right beneath the gate to serve as the bridge for thousands of vile creatures of the human realm that rushed out of the portal.

"Weird, the air here!" *Shriek!*

"Hurts, my nose and throat!" *Shriek!*

“Hurts, my eyes because of your face!” *Shriek!*

“Still invade, we!” *Shriek!*

“Still conquer, we!” *Shriek!*

“Still fight, we!” *Shriek!*

“Invade! Conquer! Fight!” *Shriek!*

Orcish warriors, whose size was certainly not inferior to that of demons, flooded out through the hell’s gate. They stepped on Draggy’s head, ran down its bony spine, and rushed to the ground of the underworld. That was when demons finally realized what was going on.

“S-stop them!”

“Get rid of the bone dragon first!”

“Aaack!”

Demons let out their creepy battle cries and charged towards the bone dragon Draggy. Getting rid of this colossal creature was their biggest priority, as creatures of the human realm were descending through this from the portal. They unleashed fiery breaths from their mouths. The hell’s fire from 6,000 blazed towards one leg of Draggy, engulfing the hind limb with grudging fire.

Creak! Creak!

And Draggy loved it. The bone dragon actually enjoyed the heat massage on its leg every time it came to the underworld, and took a quick glance at the demons to signal them to attack the other leg as well. The demons’ understanding of the peril they were in drastically became sharper.

“Break that thing apart!”

Shring! Clink! The demons stretched out their hands, causing their arm bones to extend and protrude through their palms. They then took the shape

of grim weapons of each individual's choice, not to mention the horrifying facial expressions.

"Graaaah!"

Strong demons charged, but they couldn't attack Draggy. Their marching had been stopped by brave orc warriors.

"Big, they, like us!" *Shriek!*

"Muscle, they, like us!" *Shriek!*

"Fight, I want!" *Shriek!*

"Date, I want!" *Shriek!*

"...There's a spy among us!" *Shriek!*

Orc warriors shouted out in response to the battle cry of the demons, each holding a battle axe, hammer, and steel mace.

Boooooooooom!

They charged and clashed with one another. Muscles flexed, tusks shone, and fists were clenched. They bit and pulled and stomped. But the orcs were pushed back.

"Strong, they are!" *Shriek!*

"Hit me, that guy!" *Shriek!*

"In there, hang!" *Shriek!*

The orc warriors stood their ground despite the adversities, however, as in amphibious warfare. They did their best to make way for other soldiers of the alliance to cross the portal and descend on Draggy's spine, joining forces with the orcs.

30,000 orcs all charged recklessly, as 10,000 Royal Magentano soldiers marched in a precise formation, accompanied by 500 centauri sprinters carrying elf sharpshooters and 500 White Cavalry on the left wing, and 1,200 Mamluk cavalry on the right. 36 artillerymen from Cremo escorted by 700 pikemen from Namaran followed from behind, eventually pushing the demons back.

“Argh! Ack! H-hold on!”

But there was no such thing as a time-out in war. The alliance forces continued to mercilessly rout their enemies, putting pressure on the demons with headstrong orcs and well-organized royal soldiers, while the fleet-footed centauri, White Cavalry, elf sharpshooters, and Mamluk cavalry ran around and caught them from behind quickly.

6,500 demons were surrounded, just like that. Artilleries from Cremo were fired, and demons got knocked out from the projectiles here and there. Some demons went wild in fury, but only to be held by the flexing muscles of orc warriors in the vicinity. Some demons tried to flee, but were hunted down by the arrows of elf sharpshooters. The tide of the battle had certainly turned. Lloyd clenched his fist as he watched from above.

Good. Perfect.

It was a complete victory. In fact, he had anticipated this much.

Because we invaded after incapacitating the hell’s knights.

Each of the hell’s knights was mightier than a swordmaster. The ascension of one of these frightening creatures was enough to obliterate a single nation, but there were 500 of them. It was indeed horrifying just to consider what kind of havoc they could have wreaked.

Me, Javier, and my queen. There are only three swordmasters even in the Kingdom of Magentano, which is definitely the lordly dominion in the entire continent. Other kingdoms? One or two at max.

Swordmasters were that hard to come by, but 500 warriors more powerful than that rare commodity had invaded. But Lloyd had successfully incapacitated them with a young dragon and 1,000 mermaid warriors.

I was able to minimize the damage to the estate thanks to that.

Focusing on defense alone was going to devastate the lands. In fact, Lake Kapua had already been damaged due to the execution of the holy flood, not to mention peripheral losses.

The waterworks are all gone, the bridge got swept away, and Maritz Farmland lost a third of its land to flood. I gotta repay all of that and drain the water out... Ugh.

Lloyd barely managed to contain his tears from falling, thinking about the monetary deficit. He had to strengthen his resolve again.

I'm not going to be in the deficit!

He remembered how much effort he had put into constructing the waterworks, bridge, and Maritz Farmlands. Lloyd shouted out to the alliance forces with anger from his heart.

"Remember to focus on capturing the demons alive!"

Lloyd was determined to apprehend all of them as prisoners of war, before sentencing them to ruthless labor without pay. But that couldn't happen without accomplishing one feat.

The king of hell. He's the biggest obstacle.

Lloyd knew he had to capture the lord of the underworld alive in order to put a stop to this madness. He strengthened his resolve once again and took a glance at Sir Giolexius, riding on his hell's steed next to him.

"Sir Lexi. Does it feel strange to be here like this?"

"What do you mean?"

“You know. Whether you feel like a traitor or not.”

“Not at all, my liege. Please don’t worry.”

“Really?”

“Yes, my lord,” replied Sir Giolexius, nodding his heavy head. “You are my liege now, although it is only a five-year employment contract.”

“Then can you perform your duty to navigate us through the underworld?”

“As you wish, my lord.”

“Good. Let’s do this. You perform well today, and the next employment contract will be for a permanent position.”

“Understood.”

Sir Giolexius’s ribcage vibrated in excitement at the term *permanent position.* For the past three months, he had experienced workplace benefits in the Frontera Estate, for the first time in his life.

It felt strange in the beginning to have a cozy place of my own and enjoy the rest there after the established work schedule. Even humans weren’t afraid of me. Sir Draggy and senior members of the skeletal corp were actually very kind.

He had even gotten paid on time. This was the first form of kindness and benefit he had been the receiving end of, as a hell’s knight.

And if it’s possible... that’s how I want to live the rest of my life until my bones become dust.

Sir Giolexius knew he had to enter into a permanent employment contract in that case. He was determined to, and he was convinced he could. He strengthened his resolve and clenched his fist, reminding himself of the duty he was assigned today: navigating.

“I can sense the energy of the king of hell from there,” the hell’s knight pointed to the north.

“That way? How far?” Lloyd asked with sparkly eyes.

“Quite a distance, but we can get there in ten minutes if we hop on Sir Draggy’s back and fly in full speed.”

“That should do. Did you all hear him?”

Lloyd turned around and glanced at the mightiest warriors of the alliance army. Javier was ready. Lloyd’s queen was eager to enter into battle, Raphael’s halo was burning more fiercely than ever, orc warrior Arosh was flexing his muscles, Elf archer Moira was calmly inspecting her bow and arrows, and colossal creatures Draggy and Bibeong boasted of their sheer size. Because they hadn’t engaged the demons in the battle, they were all teeming with energy. Lloyd glanced at this group of mighty fine warriors who were ready to give their everything against a single enemy and asked them.

“Are you ready to hunt down the king of hell?”

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Chapter 395: Underworld Conquest (2)

“Are you ready to hunt down the king of hell?”

Lloyd’s bold question was heard loud and clearly by those that followed. They lifted their heads and glanced at the estate developer, with similar thoughts in their minds.

He is indeed one of a kind.

Raphael, the angel of thrones, gulped nervously as he recalled what this human had performed throughout the day.

Can anyone else in this world do this well against the hell’s army? Has anyone?

There hadn’t been a single soul in the entire world and the heavenly realm.

The heavenly realm engaged the underworld in massive warfare about five times, excluding minor altercations. And it was an immensely huge one each time.

It was mostly a stalemate, with neither side being able to take decisive advantage. Their battles would influence the human realm as well.

A great extinction took place every time there was a war because the ecosystem in the human realm was affected. But Lloyd Frontera’s war is different.

The estate developer was leading others in clean warfare, completely preventing such byproducts. He dominated the opponents without heading into a deadlock or being pushed back once.

This is a completely one-sided victory that even the heavenly realm has never achieved.

Raphael was astounded by how an ordinary human had made this accomplishment. It was jaw-dropping. Hell's knight Sir Giolexius standing next to Raphael thought likewise.

Thank goodness I got a new job.

Sir Giolexius clenched his fist behind everyone's back. He had had his concerns before this battle. Despite having disowned the king of hell, this frightening creature was still his former liege, and going up against him was certainly uncomfortable. Sir Giolexius even had worried about Lloyd's defeat. However, his new employer was literally dominating hell's army through genius tactics, causing the hell's knight to feel more loyal towards the new organization he worked for. It was likewise for each of the other comrades-in-arms.

Shriek! What a lucky day! I get to train my muscles more properly! Shriek!

Orc Arosh sniffed like a pig, excited by the grand battle.

There's literally no vegetation here. I suppose it is what hell would look like. Maybe I can plant some seeds here after the war and see how that goes.

Elf Moira strengthened her resolve internally to conquer this wretched place. The plan to attack the king of hell had to work.

"Alright, let's get going then! Hop on!" Lloyd shouted.

Draggy crouched down to allow everyone to get on its back while holding Bibeong in its arms. With robust flapping of its skeletal wings, Draggy's flight kicked off at explosive speed.

Kwoosh!

"That way!"

Lloyd pointed in the direction told by Sir Giolexius, and Draggy soared through hell's sky. The fierce wind hit the warrior's faces like a tsunami as Lloyd did the math in his head.

Ten minutes until we face the king of hell. Whew. I hope we're not too late.

Lloyd suspected the king of hell had nearly completely incarnated himself in the lich's body by now, expecting to open his eyes in the new body soon.

Come on. If we could get there before he actually does, our job would become much easier.

That would be the best possible scenario and the greatest achievement by far.

That's like hitting the lottery ten times in a row after letting the machine pick the numbers automatically.

Or perhaps even greater. But Lloyd felt a strong glare from his side and turned his head.

"...Why are you staring at me like that?"

"Because I have my doubts," said Javier with his characteristic stare, as his silver hair flew against the wind. "Do you really think we can defeat the king of hell with just us?"

"That's what worries you?"

"Yeah," nodded Javier adamantly. "Even if he's incarnating himself into a different body, he's still the king of hell. Without a special plan, this fight is a suicide mission."

"So it is."

"..."

"What. Why."

"I take it that you have devised a strange tactic again then?"

"What do you mean a strange tactic?"

“You were always like that. Even today,” said Javier, with a subtle chuckle on his lips. “But I’m glad we’re actually battling away from our home. I can’t imagine what kind of damages our estate would have suffered if we fought there.”

“True. And the king of hell will probably be furious that we brought the battle to the underworld.”

“Yeah. Because he actually took time and effort to incarnate himself in the lich’s body to invade the human realm.”

“But we came here instead before he even stepped a foot up there.”

“...Ha.”

Javier failed to contain his laughter and chuckled out loud. Lloyd responded with a satisfactory smile of his own.

“So just trust in your big bro, because I know what I’m doing.”

“If you insist.”

“I do insist. One more thing. Don’t overstretch yourself.”

“It looks like I will have to today, though.”

“No. We’ll fail if you do.”

“What do you mean?”

“You’ll find out soon enough.”

“...Hold up.”

“What now.”

“You saw the result of this battle through the Jewel of Truth, then.”

“Something like that.”

“Did you see our victory?”

“...”

Lloyd looked back and saw the lingering cold stare from Javier’s eyes. He did not know how to respond, because giving him the honest answer was going to make him vehemently oppose the tactic. Lloyd had to make a decision.

“Yeah. Our side is going to win.”

Lloyd gave a half-true answer. Javier finally seemed relieved to hear the reply, and Lloyd thought that was enough. Today’s victory was going to happen, regardless of what it takes, anyway.

“Get ready. We’re almost there.”

Lloyd barely managed to contain his emotions from bursting out. This wasn’t the time to get sentimental, as there was a huge and last obstacle to overcome just yet.

“Listen carefully to what I tell you, and do exactly as I say. Okay?”

Lloyd strengthened his resolve and shared the detailed plan with Javier, as he looked at a certain point across the horizon.

***

“They’re here.”

Inhale.

This was where the last terminal of the Hell Express was constructed. This was where countless souls entered through the gate of rebirth. The king of hell couldn’t vacate this place even in his slumber while he was incarnating himself in a new body, in order to avoid the shutdown of the underworld’s operation. The mighty creature opened his eyes in the middle of the huge platform. He actually saw everything despite the closed eyes, yet hadn’t moved an inch. Instead, he sat still and watched the events unfold like a

spectator. It was fun, exciting, and absolutely satisfying to find out he was right.

“I knew I was right about the talent Lloyd Frontera... I mean, Suho Kim possessed. He will turn out to be the best subject I’ve ever had.”

Vibrate.

The statement resonated deeply within the king of hell’s head, as Bibeong landed at the end of the platform followed by Draggy. The king of hell’s grin became even more apparent.

“Welcome, Suho Kim.”

“Welcome my ass. Don’t grin like that, because you now look like the entire haunted house with the lich’s face.”

Lloyd replied with mockery instead. But the king of hell’s grim smile through the lich’s desolate face became stronger.

“Good. That’s what I wanted to hear. That’ll make crushing you and making you serve me even more worthwhile.”

“...”

“I realized that you were going to keep declining my request if I didn’t get involved myself. But because I couldn’t harm you in my original body due to the rules, I found myself a new body to house my soul. How do you like it?”

Stretch! The king of hell stretched out his two hands, and that was enough to exert a tremendous amount of pressure in the air. But even that was only a glimpse of the lich’s endless supply of violent mana, empowered by the superior and transcendent powers the king of hell possessed. The hot, steamy air of the underworld instantly became cold, causing everyone to flinch inadvertently. Queen Alicia frowningly raised her spirits, Raphael let his fiery halo burn even more ferociously, Sir Giolexius shook his bony

structure, the orc Arosh let out a deep breath, and the elf Moira inadvertently drew her arrow. But Lloyd was undisturbed.

“Whoa. Just look at this high-performance air conditioner.”

“...”

“Can you do it again? This is actually very refreshing. I think you even got rid of all the volcanic ashes and fine dust with it.”

“...”

“You don’t have to if you don’t want to.”

“...Ahem. Suho Kim.”

“I’m listening.”

“It’s still not too late.”

“What.”

“Kneel and bow before me. Beg for your life and ask for the merciful power of the underworld so you may serve me in death. This is not that difficult.”

“But it is.”

“No. It’s actually extremely easy. All you have to do is change your mind and ask me for this favor. You’ll be given the power that no other vassals that serve me have been granted. You’ll be set permanently.”

“Like, a high position in the underworld?”

“Yeah. You’ll be the most powerful person, only second to me, in the entire underworld. A man must have that much ambition to lead a meaningful life.”

“Meaningful life... I think I get it.”

“Ha. Finally.”

“Yeah,” nodded Lloyd, as he glared at the king of hell and tilted his head to one side. “That’s exploitation of labor.”

“...What?”

“Is there honey in the underworld?”

“Honey?”

“Yeah. Honey that is so sweet, that it retains its amazing taste even when dissolved in water.”

“...No.”

“That’s where the problem comes from,” said Lloyd with a blatant look of disappointment. “Think about it. There’s no honey here, or anything fun to do. And it’s not like the nature is amazing. Volcanoes erupt frequently, lava flows, and the average temperature is far higher than tropical rainforests. The presence of volcanic ashes makes it impossible to live without a mask.”

“...”

“And you’re telling me I can have so much power to rule over this wretched place? Let’s be real. This is a scam offer.”

Lloyd’s voice gradually became louder, as if he just realized that he had been enticed to buy a buy-one-get-one-free item at a more expensive price than buying two items separately. He pointed out the sugar-coated offer, in reality, is nothing but an invitation to servitude without proper compensation. He was getting slightly worked up.

“Give me a break. Listen. If you want to recruit someone to work for you, at least establish a plausible workplace environment. But take a look here. There are no public facilities, no infrastructure, no schools here. Are you seriously asking me to work in a place where the real estate property is absolutely unlikely to go up in value in the next one million years? What good is there to exercise my authority in a dreadful place like this?”

“But Suho Kim.”

“I’ve heard enough. You’re offering nothing substantial save for the sugar-coated words of honor. And you expect me to accept the position where I’ll be exploited to provide labor for the rest of my life? Do you take me for a fool or something? Is this all you are?”

“Suho Kim!”

“Yeah.”

“Think again. I advise you to stop looking at it from the narrow-minded human perspective.”

“Why?”

“You will go down in history as a legendary and mythical figure in the human world.”

“And?”

“Isn’t that amazing?”

“Amazing? But there’s no honey here.”

“...”

“If you don’t like my answer, let’s at least see the draft of the employment contract you prepared.”

“Employment... what?”

“I knew it,” replied Lloyd with a sneer. “You didn’t prepare anything.”

“There is no need for documentation between us.”

“Of course there is.”

“I am the king of hell. I am the ruler of the eternal purgatory and the being that oversees death and rebirth. Why would I need to draft a stinking contract to have you serve under me?”

“...Ha.”

Lloyd bitterly chuckled at the king of hell’s question. The estate developer’s stare became colder and his voice more cynical as he added.

“I knew it. All terrible employers always give this kind of evasively angry response when asked about the employment contract.”

“What?”

“Do you honestly think the title king of hell or ruler of purgatory offers any bit of credibility? Unexpected events and accidents are bound to happen during one’s tenure. How do you plan to take care of those unforeseen cases without the written contract?”

“The hell is--“

“Hell, hell, hell. I’ve heard enough about your hell. Malicious mployers that try to exploit desperate workers always say the same thing. They emphasize the relationship between them and the workers is like a familial one so there is no need to get upset about the lack of written guidelines, and stuff. Family, my ass. It’s more like slavery.”

“...”

“People like you bend the rules and skip the contract part, only to cheat off your employees by holding off on their wages later on. There is no extra pay for overtime or doing things that are outside of the job description. There is no vacation. Yet you demand the workers to show up before work hours and leave way after five. Each time an employee complains about it, you sugarcoat your acts of exploitation with phrases like *you’ve learned about the passion, you’ve gotten experience, and that’s way more valuable than the wage that’s being withheld at the moment, and that you should thank me instead.* That kind of bullcrap.”

“What are you--“

“Am I wrong? You so proudly mentioned the highest position second only to the king in the underworld, powers that I’d be given, and my name going down in history as the legendary and mythical figure in the human world. That’s no different from those empty promises that are not substantial at all. I won’t be gaining a dime through all that. You’ll be the sole beneficiary of the fruit of my labor. What difference is there between you and those atrocious bastards that will enjoy luxury while their employees struggle to put food on the table with minimum wage?”

“Suho Kim.”

“Don’t call me like that. You don’t even have anything good in your land.”

“Suho Kim!” Shouted the king of hell in genuine fury at Lloyd’s sharp words. He was so infuriated that he had failed to suspect the blade being drawn behind him, while Lloyd was grabbing his attention with his tongue.

Shring.

“...!”

Before the king of hell could rise from his seat, grandmaster Javier’s all-out thrusting of his sword pierced through the deathly ruler’s chest.

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Chapter 396: Last Resort (1)

Pierce! A bluish aura protruded from the king of hell's chest.

"Ha," the king of hell paused and glanced at the blade that had pierced his chest.

Kwoosh! And it did not stop there.

Aura was divided into multiple strands and turned into a storm in an instant, cutting through and splitting everything, from the demon's chest to the actual space. The lich's withered-up body in which the king of hell had incarnated was shredded apart to pieces, spreading dry dust everywhere instead of blood. Limbs were detached and fell to the ground, as did the head on the butchered torso.

It worked!

Lloyd clenched his fist, seeing Javier's surprise attack land on his adversary. He had verbally abused the king of hell and hurled insults as best as he could for this moment, concealing the grandmaster's presence.

Even if you're the king of hell, you can't really do anything without the body.

Lloyd suspected it would at least have delivered significant damage. But the orc Arosh sniffed and stated the tabooed phrase.

"We got him." *Shriek!*

"...Dude."

"What's wrong?" *Shriek!*

"Don't say that. You're going to jinx--"

"You'd be disheartened to know that the surprise attack was to no avail."

It was the king of hell's voice, as Lloyd tried to hush Arosh. The estate developer flinched and glanced at the bodily debris from the attack, and noticed the head was staring straight at his face without losing signs of life in its eyes. It even moved its jaw robustly and added.

"I knew you were trying to grab my attention with such sharp words. I was waiting to see what kind of surprise you'd have prepared for me, but it's extremely disappointing."

Fwoosh.

The shredded body of the king of hell was shrouded by dark, opaque dust, reconstructing a dark silhouette of a whole lich again. The shape became apparent as the dismembered body parts floated in the air and assembled again.

"Javier!"

The grandmaster did not hesitate as soon as he heard the shout. Javier's sword flashed intensely as he slashed through the space in all directions. However, it still fell short of the king of hell. Different parts of the lich's body had maneuvered in different ways as though they were independent entities to avoid the attack.

"Everyone!" Shouted out Lloyd, as he tightened the grip on his shovel.

The queen extended her aura into her sword, hell's knight Sir Giolexius's armor transformed into his trusted steed, Raphael held the hammer of judgment in his hands, orc Arosh swung his battleaxe and charged, and elf Moira drew her bow. Draggy and Bibeong lifted their forearms to help.

Kwoosh!

The forearm attacks of two colossal beasts, weighing 4,000 tons in total, fell on the lich's body and crushed it into the pit 15 feet deep and 200 feet wide, created on the platform from the attack. But even that wasn't enough.

Fwoosh.

“Bibeong?”

A single strand of dark dust found itself out through the exerting fingers of Bibeong and formed a shape in the air again, reconstructing the king of hell’s body.

“So this is the type of futile resistance you had planned all along.”

The king of hell stretched out the wand on his right hand after the body became whole again.

“I suppose it’s my turn to pay back.”

The skull at the tip of the wand unleashed an ominous glow.

Ding-dong!

A red message popped up in front of Lloyd suddenly.

[Warning: Danger!]

[Skill Option 7: Urgent Foresight is activated.]

[Your body temperature increases by 2°F due to the effect of the relic Eye of the Summer.]

Whoosh!

Lloyd’s mana heart began operating itself without Lloyd’s realization, as the relic Eye of the Summer heated his body up, shortly before roughly showing him 5 seconds into the future.

“...Everyone!”

Lloyd attempted to shout out and warn the others of what he saw, but it was too late. Before he could finish, something flashed above his head and charged towards him, not giving him a moment of peace, followed by detonations beneath his feet as if he had stepped on landmines or was

running through a field being bombarded. A huge explosion swept through the place, engulfing it with a storm of dark purplish flames.

Lloyd had barely managed to respond in time and jumped to the side, avoiding losing his leg. However, the scope of the enemy's attack was too vast.

"Ack!"

Lloyd flew more than 50 feet aback, seeing the sky and the ground exchange their positions several times in the process. He couldn't even dream of landing properly from the physical damage and the dizziness it involved. The estate developer urgently covered his head with his arms. That was a good decision.

Tumble. Thud! Thump! Roll! Thud!

He fell on the ground and rolled several times, only to be stopped by a boulder.

"...Huff, huff. Ugh."

Lloyd questioned if he was a disassembled Lego set from the pain. He touched his own body, trying to see if his limbs were still intact and his torso whole. He then picked up the shovel again and lifted his head, seeing another message in the air.

Ding-dong!

[Warning: The effectiveness of your Mana Heart and Mana Circle is reduced by 20%.]

What...?!

Lloyd was in disbelief as he read the continuous warning messages.

[You have sustained damage both physically and spiritually.]

[Should you take similar hits like this 2 more times, you will lose 60% of your Mana Heart and Mana Circle capacity and enter into a state of severe disarray.]

[Should you take similar hits like this 3 more times, you will lose 80% of your Mana Heart and Mana Circle capacity and enter into a state of displacement from the disconnection between your physical body and the soul.]

[Should you take similar hits like this 4 more times, you will lose 100% of your Mana Heart and Mana Circle capacity and die permanently.]

What kind of...

It was outrageous, but Lloyd knew not to undermine the warnings. In fact, he felt the reduced effectiveness of the mana heart and the circle firsthand.

Zing...

"...Ugh." *Cough!*

Lloyd felt the tension around his chest. It was as if his mana circle had just become rusty; it indicated one thing.

I don't know if that's a physical or a magic attack... but it definitely affects the soul and the mana of the target. A few hits will definitely kill me.

But the king of hell was pointing his wand towards Lloyd again when he identified the nature of the strike. Another intense flash fell from the sky.

Damn it!

He hadn't even gotten up from the ground, let alone regained energy. Lloyd quickly attempted to rise, or even crawl out of the area if he could, seeing a series of messages in red font in front of him.

[Warning: Danger!]

His body temperature rose without his consent again, showing him five minutes into the future.

“Hold tightly onto me.”

“Huh?”

That was when a hand of salvation held Lloyd by his shoulders and pulled him out of the path. Momentarily after they jumped, something fell from the sky and the ground exploded once again.

Kwoosh!

“...Javier?” It took some time for Lloyd to realize who had come to his rescue.

“Are you alright?”

“Not at all,” replied Lloyd, shaking his head vehemently before shouting out to his allies. “Everyone, be careful! That attack seems to affect your soul and the body at the same time! A few hits or even scratches by it can take your life!”

Everyone nodded at the estate developer. Queen Alicia grinned ferociously as she did.

I don’t think anyone can take more than a few hits anyway.

Her palms became sweaty from fear and thrill. While these two emotions contradicted one another, she harbored both and raised her fighting spirit. Her blade unleashed fearsome noises as she charged forth.

Kwoosh!

I shall strike before the enemy has time to respond with magic!

The queen found herself at a distance of ten feet from the adversary, which was just perfect for her to slay her foe with the enlarged aura slash.

Whoooosh!

Queen Alicia immediately swung her sword horizontally, unleashing the fiftten-feet-tall aura blade to slash through the space. But this ferocious attack was negated so effortlessly, by a nonchalant swing of the king of hell's hand.

Tap!

It was an ordinary movement. The king of hell causally tilted his head like he had just stopped a child's punch. Queen Alicia was appalled.

It didn't work at all?!

That was an understatement. In fact, the king of hell hadn't even budged. She even noticed the palm, which had been cut halfway from the attack, was regenerating in real-time.

Urgh...!

But the queen did not panic. She had retracted her sword the moment the attack was stopped and was turning clockwise in a skillful manner to avoid the wand attack by the king of hell. The attack fortunately missed the target as the queen shouted out.

"Lord Angel of Thrones!"

Swoosh!

The hammer of judgment fell on the lich as soon as the queen spoke. The angel of thrones descended from the sky like lightning.

"Hraah!"

Bolstered by the ring of flames behind his back, the angel of thrones exerted all of his divine angelic strength into this attack and swung his hammer vertically with the intent to crush the king of hell.

Thwoosh!

The king of hell's skull was smashed down, shortly before three arrows fired by Moira pierced the crumbling forehead. Or Arosh charged forth and swung his battleaxe against the lich's legs, causing him to stagger.

Draggy subsequently swung its massive tail.

Whoosh! Thump!

The king of hell's body floated in the air from the impact, and Bibeong quickly spiked it down like a volleyball. Sir Giolexius was waiting on the ground.

"Hi-yah!"

Pierce!

Sir Giolexius's greatsword pierced the king of hell in the chest. But Javier did not give his enemy time to respond and unleashed a slash attack immediately.

Thwoosh!

And it literally destroyed the lich's skull. However, the headless king of hell lifted his wand once and summoned another flash above everyone's head, followed by a huge explosion.

Booooooom!

Everyone except Javier flew backward from the impact. Queen Alicia, Raphael the angel, hell's knight Sir Giolexius, orc Arosh, elf Moira, Draggy, and Bibeong were all unable to avoid the attack; they were swept by the deadly detonation and rolled on the ground. Lloyd, who was watching from a distance away as he tried to regain his focus, saw the whole thing unfold.

Is that like a meteorite smash? That's like orbital bombardment.

It wasn't a small object falling from the sky like a shooting star. Even though Lloyd was a swordmaster, he couldn't even see what was

bombarding the ground. He only saw a quick glimpse of the object before flashes nearly blinded him.

It was way too fast.

He imagined the intercontinental ballistic missiles that fell from the geostationary orbit. He had read that the speed of this missile exceeded Mach 25 upon entering the Earth's atmosphere. The bombardment certainly reminded him of that.

That's five miles per second.

It sent chills down Lloyd's spine. The king of hell was glaring at the estate developer again after recovering from all those attacks.

None of our attacks are working. He recovered from all that, and even from Javier's slash like it was nothing.

Lloyd suspected it was because the king of hell had incarnated himself in the body of a lich, which was virtually immortal. Combined with the power of the ruler of the underworld, the enemy was nearly invincible.

He won't die. We can't. He can summon meteorites at the speed of 5 miles per second without casting time, which can kill us in an instant. Even getting swept indirectly by the explosion will get us eventually.

Lloyd wondered how he could overcome this, or if there even was a way. Even though he had already asked the Jewel of Truth and saw the outcome of today's battle, it was way more devastating to witness it firsthand. All hopes were fading away, as Javier continued to charge towards the king of hell all by himself.

Would Javier be able to do it?

Lloyd genuinely hoped. Maybe, just maybe, the grandmaster could defeat the king of hell. But that hope was crushed shortly.

Flash! Kaboom!!

A series of flashes fell on Javier, who barely managed to respond in time. But even he wasn't able to get away from the scope of the bombardment entirely; he flew several yards before landing, faltering throughout the process. He had most definitely sustained some damage.

That means...

Lloyd's heart began pounding, as he was reminded of the answer the Jewel of Truth had given him.

I suppose I knew that was the only way. Nothing else was going to work, and I should have resorted to this method from the get-go.

But he did not want to. He despised the idea. Even though Lloyd knew the Jewel of Truth would only speak the truth, the last answer it gave was absolutely ridiculous. That was why the estate developer tried to come up with other ways to defeat the king of hell, but they all seemed ineffective. It was hopeless.

The more I think about it...

There was no other way. Holding onto false hope was going to put his allies in greater peril.

Realizing this, Lloyd bit his lips tightly with the intent to execute the plan suggested by the Jewel of Truth. Lloyd coldly stared at his adversary after having decided to turn to the last resort, to ultimately smile at the end of the final battle.

I'm so sorry, Javier.

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Chapter 397: Last Resort (2)

I’m so sorry, Javier.

Bite! Lloyd bit his lips tightly and strengthened his resolve, barely managing to lift his body.

Ugh.

Simply standing up on his two legs from the ground gave the estate developer excruciating pain in all of his joints and muscle cells, as though he had just rolled down the stairs at least three stories tall.

But this is the only way. I should have resorted to this method from the start.

Lloyd regretted the false hope he had despite having seen the future through the Jewel of Truth, for causing his allies to sustain major to minor injuries.

“Everyone...”

He stepped forward and saw another meteorite bombardment along with the flash. The ground exploded, sending Arosh flying unconsciously in the air. Elf Moira also got swept away by the explosion and let go of her bow, and the queen rolled on the ground before losing consciousness while trying to avoid the attack. Raphael’s shield broke, and Sir Giolexius’s body was destroyed from the waist down. Draggy had lost both of its wings while protecting Bibeong, who was too huge and thus vulnerable. The gigantic beaver also got knocked out in the process.

Everyone...

Lloyd was truly sorry. He had hoped for an ending in which everyone could laugh together, but it seemed that it was unlikely. There was no other way now.

“Your Demonic Majesty!” Lloyd took a deep breath and shouted, causing the king of hell to pause and glance at him. “I think we can still talk this

over!”

“Talk?”

“Yeah!”

“What’s there to talk about?”

The king of hell tilted his head, still glaring at Lloyd through freakish eyes. It wasn’t a friendly look by any means.

Obviously.

After all, Lloyd had grabbed his attention with words, while asking Javier to unleash a surprise attack before. The estate developer tried to appear truly apologetic about the incident that gave rise to the distrust.

“It looks like I was mistaken!”

“Mistaken?”

“Yeah! I think I realize it now!”

Lloyd shouted out and took another step forward, reducing the distance between him and the king of hell slowly but surely as he continued to work his lips.

“Remember the employment contract I mentioned before? Would you be so kind as to draft one?”

“Employment contract? What difference does a piece of paper make?”

“A whole lot,” replied Lloyd. He was being truthful. “First of all, that would make me genuinely grateful and passionate about the service I provide.”

“Genuinely grateful and passionate... But I don’t see the point.”

“Huh?”

“Because I can just kill you.”

“But forcing me to do something would make me do half-assed jobs.”

“It doesn’t matter.”

“Why not?”

“Because I can boss around any citizen of the underworld, regardless of that creature’s will. I can assume control over your mind and your soul and make you provide labor wholeheartedly.”

“...”

“And that’s probably the easiest for me. Why would I draft an employment contract for someone I can order around like a faithful slave with a simple gesture of my hands?”

“Holy...”

Lloyd realized the king of hell wasn’t an easy foe to persuade; he was intent on just killing Lloyd. The estate developer slightly regretted having agitated him with sharp words before and put on the most benevolent smile he could and added.

“But please reconsider and think from a different perspective, Your Evil Majesty.”

“What’s there to think about?”

“Think of what kind of difference someone like me would make if I genuinely provided the services from the bottom of my heart.”

“Hmm.”

“There surely will be a difference between the work by a soulless slave and that by someone truly motivated to do his absolute best. Don’t you think?”

“Hmm.”

“That’s why I ask you to draft me the employment contract.”

“And you would swear fealty to me?”

“Well...”

“I’m listening.”

“That depends on the terms and conditions.”

“How dare you try to negotiate the terms with me!”

“But that’s the purpose of the employment contract, milord.”

Lloyd’s smile became even kinder as he continued moving towards the adversary, enduring the dirty looks with the back of his head. Angel of Thrones Raphael and Sir Giolexius, both of whom were most definitely incapacitated, were staring at him in disbelief.

Please don’t tell me you’re going to betray us.

Lloyd kept the bitter laughter from leaking out. He was truly sorry and felt bad for having to resort to this method, after the faith his comrades had displayed by accompanying him here.

I am truly sorry, everyone.

The estate developer held the bitterness inside and maintained the business-like smile on the surface, sucking up to the king of hell like a salesperson meeting with his richest client.

“That’s why I ask. I’m sure we can come to an agreement on terms and conditions to both parties’ satisfaction, as long as we discuss it and make compromises here and there. And that would motivate me to provide the best service I can possibly offer anyone. Oh, and please take a look at this.”

Lloyd reached out to his inner pocket and took out a few pieces of documents, which he had prepared just in case.

“What’s this?”

“These are sample employment contracts in case you’d like to refer to them.”

“Sample to refer to?”

“Yeah.”

Lloyd quickly handed the documents over, giving the king of hell no time to think about it. The freakish lord inadvertently took the documents and tried to unfold the folded documents, but he couldn’t.

Thwoosh!

Lloyd’s shovel had smacked the king of hell on the side of his face, caving in a part of the skull. King of hell faltered to the side as Lloyd shouted out furiously.

“Sample for reference my ass! This is what it entails!”

Thump! Bang! Thwoosh!

The shovel danced along to the gruesome melody of violence. The sample documents flew in the air, but there was nothing written on them; they were all blank. Lloyd’s eyes lit up.

Good. It’s going as planned.

Lloyd tightened his grip on the shovel, knowing he couldn’t give the king of hell a moment. He had to continue attacking his adversary when he had a chance. Knowing this, he swung his shovel in various directions to smack the enemy’s legs, waist, head, calf, and waist again.

Thump! Kabam! Bang! Whack! Slam!

Lloyd smashed the foe’s head with his shovel, whacked him with the handle, slashed him with his aura, and swept him with the mana blast. But that wasn’t the entirety of Lloyd’s attacks.

These won’t work anyway.

The king of hell had withstood the flurry of attacks by all of Lloyd’s comrades and even came back from Javier’s slash that had shredded him apart to pieces. The estate developer knew.

My attacks won’t even itch.

He knew it was ineffective but still carried on because it was a necessary step leading to the next. He strengthened his resolve and continued more intensely, keeping one eye on the king of hell’s wand as well as the colossal sickle that the enemy had drawn. And the wand moved.

Now!

Ding-dong!

[Warning: Danger!]

[Skill Option 7: Urgent Foresight is activated.]

[Your body temperature increases by 2°F due to the effect of the relic Eye of the Summer.]

Whoosh!

Lloyd’s mana heart automatically extended the mana without Lloyd’s intent as the relic Eye of the Summer’s effect was triggered. His body became hot and he saw five seconds into the future.

This way!

Lloyd shot out the mana blast towards his feet as soon as he saw the foresight.

Blast!

The beam of mana forced Lloyd’s body upward from the impact, shortly before the flash in the sky followed by the meteorite bombardment.

Kaboom!

Meteorite was the size of a baseball, but the speed of Mach 25 was devastating enough to rattle the ground amidst screeching noises and shockwaves. Lloyd had lifted his body in the air but still wasn't able to avoid it entirely.

"Urgh...!"

His body flew up even higher from the explosion despite the attempt to get out of the scope.

[Warning: The effectiveness of your Mana Heart and Mana Circle is reduced by 40%.]

Argh...!

Lloyd wondered if the piece of meat being pounded by the hammer would feel this way as red warning messages continued to pop up.

[You have sustained damage both physically and spiritually.]

[Should you take similar hits like this 1 more time, you will lose 60% of your Mana Heart and Mana Circle capacity and enter into a state of severe disarray.]

[Should you take similar hits like this 2 more times...]

Ugh.

Lloyd couldn't tell if he was nauseous because he was being flown back or because he had sustained a significant blow. He felt his mana heart and circle swirl around rapidly, but couldn't even land on the ground as the king of hell had charged forth even before Lloyd's inadvertent, deadly flight could end.

Ding-dong!

[Warning: Danger!]

[Skill Option 7: Urgent Foresight is activated.]

[Your body temperature increases by 2°F due to the effect of the relic Eye of the Summer.]

Whoosh!

It became even hotter. Lloyd saw five seconds into the future again amid severe migraines, as it suggested the horizontal swing of the colossal sickle beheading the estate developer. Lloyd quickly turned his body in time.

Sping!

Ouch!

The sickle scraped his ear. Lloyd felt severe heat in the affected area as he saw the drops of blood in the air, slightly obstructing his view of the new red warning message.

[Warning: The effectiveness of your Mana Heart and Mana Circle is reduced by 60%.]

[You have sustained damage both physically and spiritually.]

[You enter a state of severe disarray.]

Urgh...!

Lloyd fell to the ground without a chance to respond. He couldn’t breathe normally, not from the physical pain but from the extreme fear that overwhelmed his body and soul. It was as if he had just been thrown into the endless pit of the abyss, and as if he was all alone in the dark galaxy without a single star in sight.

Huff. Huff. Gasp!

He couldn’t breathe properly. The breath became uncontrollably fast, subtle, then fast again. It didn’t even reach his lungs and lingered around his lips. It

grew faster before the oxygen was depleted and the light surrounding him faded away. He was all alone. He was out of breath. He was desperate.

Please.

And he couldn’t breathe. The air surrounding him was like invisible walls closing in on him from all directions. They approached with intense pressure and were going to squish him and laugh out loud like the king of hell.

Ugh... Huh!

It was painful. The sliced ear and the profuse bleeding, the tough breath, and the overwhelming terror that dominated him were all so excruciatingly agonizing. Lloyd crawled on the ground like a caterpillar as the king of hell approached, holding a wand in one hand and a sickle in the other. Lloyd momentarily wondered with which weapon the enemy was going to kill him. The estate developer fought off the fear combined with curiosity and tried his absolute best to continue breathing, mustering his energy to speak again.

“...Huff. Huh. Huff. Ugh. Is that... it? Huff... Pathetic... You suck... Meteorite... so small... Huff. Ugh...”

It was still all going according to the plan. Lloyd knew he had to just keep provoking him this way, enduring the immense fear, fright, despair, and torment. His perseverance was going to pay off soon. Lloyd had faith and strengthened his resolve once again. He endeavored to breathe and talk, trying to agitate the king of hell.

“...Huff. Ugh. Huff. I know... you’re a sissy... Huff. You can’t... huff, huff... unleash a bigger one... huff... because... you’re scared... you’d get swept away too... huff, huff. Coward.”

Lloyd spoke what came to his mind. He had suspected that the king of hell only unleashed small meteorites several times instead of summoning multiple huge ones to slay everyone at once.

He probably did that because, although he's invincible against our attacks, he's actually vulnerable against his own.

Lloyd was about to lose himself from it all but barely managed to keep himself together and took a glance at the king of hell's face.

Nailed it.

He was spot on. The withered-up facial expression was most certainly that of someone whose secrets had just been exposed. Lloyd knew for sure the moment he saw it.

Good.

The outcome foretold by the Jewel of Truth was right around the corner. The grand finale of this massive battle was approaching. The moment of triumphant smile was certainly coming. It was scary, frightening, and improbable, yet enjoyable. Lloyd stared at the king of hell in the eyes as the lich lifted his sickle. He thought of how to respond to the attack in his head and acted on it immediately.

With my back.

Lloyd had to take the hit with his back. He had to turn around now.

Please.

Lloyd mustered the remainder of his energy, but still couldn't move. Simply getting up and facing down again was an impossible task at the moment. He struggled, as the sickle fell on his head.

Whoosh!

Freakish noise took over as the animosity filled the air.

Please...!

There was just one more thing Lloyd had to do. He couldn't die like this. Not after all this.

Ugh... Argh!

But he had failed. Lloyd closed his eyes, realizing all of his efforts were in vain now.

Clink! Slash!

Sudden clinking noises of metal followed by a peculiar sound graced Lloyd's ears. Warm liquid was splattered on Lloyd's face. The noise hadn't come from his body, nor did the blood. Lloyd opened his eyes and saw the unbelievable.

"...Javier?"

Javier had rushed to his side and was standing in front of Lloyd with his shoulder pierced by the sickle. He slightly turned his head and smiled.

"I am so sorry, Master Lloyd."

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Chapter 398: Last Resort (3)

It hurt.

Javier inadvertently chuckled at the phrase that praised selfless behaviors.

What an outrageous bullcrap.

He could only laugh bitterly, after actually having moved his body to protect someone else and shed blood in his place.

It just hurts. A lot.

The grandmaster felt excruciating pain on his left shoulder as if it was being burned and pounded by a hammer at the same time. Lloyd was staring at his knight in surprise. The estate developer was clearly trying to say something, but couldn't. His mouth remained open for a while.

"I am so sorry, Master Lloyd."

Pierce! The tip of the sickle that had protruded forward from behind was pulled back, filling the hole in Javier's body with blood. The grandmaster bled profusely from the wound, and his left side was covered in blood. However, he couldn't go down here. He refused to kneel.

"...Why?"

The fake Lloyd barely managed to ask this question, causing Javier to chuckle yet again.

"I tried to parry it off with my blade attack but failed. I was only able to slightly mitigate the force. Otherwise, you would have sustained the injury."

Blood gushed forth, but he couldn't stop.

"This works for me. Master Lloyd, please get yourself to safety."

"Hold on--"

Javier tightened his grip on the sword and turned around, swinging the blade empowered by the remainder of his aura and his weight. It was significantly weaker than usual, but that did not matter.

Just once.

As long as he could deliver some kind of damage to the king of hell, there was hope for Javier; Lloyd could perhaps survive.

Clink!

But the attack was stopped. Javier felt the shock from the impact on his left shoulder, gushing forth blood once again. But the grip on his sword tightened.

“Hmph!”

Krakakakaka!

Javier put his everything in his attacks as he thrust, slashed, slammed, and struck. He sliced, parried, and whacked.

Krakakakaka!

Flares sparked and flew everywhere as Javier felt the pain in his left shoulder with each attack. He nearly fainted and was overwhelmed with fear. It was as if he was sustaining grave damage both physically and mentally.

But the grip on his sword tightened. Javier swung his weapon again with the determination to die if he had to here. He wasn’t going to back away, as long as that could keep that fraudster safe. That was enough for Javier. The grandmaster attacked even more fiercely and ferociously, with the intent to continue until he would breathe his last. He didn’t care if his body was going to break down to dust from all this. He continued to attack, strike, and defend.

Krakakaka! Clink! Clank!

His body was rattled. Agonizing pain shook him. He experienced near-fainting moments more often, as his vision blurred and returned several times. The world disappeared and came back. These went on for a while until Javier felt light on his feet all of a sudden.

Zing!

Even without realization, Javier had opened a new, fourth circle surrounding his heart through the series of moments that required extreme focus and reaching his limit.

Kwoosh!

The flow of aura was like that of a fierce current now, as it shrouded Javier's body. He was able to push off the sickle attack by the adversary for the first time.

Clink!

"Huh?"

The king of hell's eyes subtly shook. But it wasn't over. The change that began in Javier's heart spread out to his entire body.

He was breaking through every barrier that stood, from physicality, mentality, and to willpower. He broke through internally and externally.

Zing!

The fifth circle let out a peculiar noise as it was formed. All of Javier's 60 trillion mana hearts resonated with the cry by the pentacircle, shrouding even the ground on which the grandmaster was standing.

Ha. That won't make a difference, the king of hell chuckled.

But the sixth circle was born with a flash as if Javier's body was responding to the sneer.

Zing!

All of his bodily cells were now active, as the sixty trillion mana hearts embedded within the cells cried out. Mana was amplified as it passed through the hexacircle. Aura traveled through a total of 2,799,360,000,000,000,000—billion millions of passageways—and all met in the heart, shaking all cells, nerves, and arteries in the process. Javier then rushed forth, sprinted, broke through, and charged.

Bam!

The king of hell was shaken from the attack despite having parried off the slash. The evil ruler's face turned red from bellicose excitement.

"Astounding... Urgh!"

Slash!

King of hell's leg was gone with a single attack, but he wasn't a fan of being on the receiving end of effective strikes.

Whoosh!

He extended his sickle and swung it against Javier's throat again, while simultaneously waving his wand in the air. But Javier was not there. With a single step, the grandmaster had caught the king of hell from behind; he was faster than the wind and stealthier than a ghost.

"What?"

The king of hell felt terrorizing animosity and responded immediately.

Flash!

Another meteorite fell from the sky amidst the flash.

But Javier's sword had viciously scraped off the entire space. His blade clashed with the meteorite that was traveling at the speed of Mach 25 and released hundreds of thousands of aura strands explosively.

Kwooooooosh!

The physical impact from the clash, the massive shockwave that was about to be unleashed, and the overwhelming radiant heat that was ready to engulf the entire vicinity were all swept away by the aura strands without affecting the ground and the surroundings at all. Javier did not sustain any damage either; instead, he used the force to empower his own attack.

Ping.

There was no outrageous noise. The grandmaster smoothly maneuvered and slid between spaces like a skilled predator. He swung his sword between the air molecules.

“Oh?”

It took a moment of flinching by the king of hell.

Krakakaka!

The fiendish ruler’s left body was shredded apart into pieces, not to mention the wand. King of hell barely managed to counterattack with his sickle.

Whoosh! Swoosh!

The ten-foot-long sickle spun around gloriously, sweeping through everything in the vicinity from all directions.

Krakakakakaka!

Javier’s ruthless slashes clashed against the nefarious sickle hundreds of times in the air. The king of hell regenerated his left side in the meantime and attempted another attack.

Sping!

The mana in the area became distorted and turned into hell’s fire. The heat nearly rivaling the surface temperature of the sun engulfed Javier, but he did not panic; instead, he retracted his sword momentarily and mustered up the energy before unleashing it horizontally.

Slice!

Air and space had been cut through. The flare was trapped in the absolute void that was created in the blink of an eye. This blatant defiance of physics appalled the king of hell.

“What...?”

But he did not have a chance to sate his curiosity. Javier did not give him time.

Krakaka!

Javier’s longsword stopped immediately in front of the king of hell. He had barely stopped it. But the evil ruler of the underworld was flabbergasted nonetheless.

How can a human be this powerful?!

The king of hell knew how skilled Javier was as a swordsman, but that was as far as he had given the grandmaster credit for. He was still human and he could never overcome the physical limitations imposed on the inferior creature. This was verified time and again. Or so he thought.

He’s on a whole new level now.

It sent chills down the king of hell’s spine. The freakish ruler would have avoided facing this man in battle in his own body because he would be governed by the law of death.

I would have been in danger.

Even the dictator of the treacherous underworld had to risk his own life to engage Javier in this state in battle. However, the king of hell was in a different body at the moment.

Thank goodness I incarnated myself in the lich’s body.

The king of hell chuckled in relief, for the lich's body was immortal. He was invincible. He was invulnerable.

Javier Asrahan. It doesn't matter what you do now. You may be able to cut me down, shred me apart, or even crush me to pieces. But nothing you do will kill me. This is a battle you cannot possibly win.

Even if he was to break apart, be crushed, and slashed over and over again, he was immortal. He could regenerate any damage effortlessly in an instant. On the other hand, Javier Asrahan was still human. Despite the fierceness of his attacks, he was still going to come short. That made the king of hell genuinely relieved.

The evil dictator did not panic one bit despite being slashed, shredded, and pierced by Javier's ferocious attacks. Instead, he enjoyed the sight of his adversary's endeavor. The grandmaster's tremendous effort to come up victorious was rather fun. He watched as a spectator. He was the more skilled and taller basketball player against a shorter novice on the court. It was a form of mockery. The king of hell regenerated each time he took damage, and sustained hits all over again. He would cast powerful offensive spells here and there to make the process more interesting for his foe, encouraging him to try harder. The king of hell was virtually staring down at his opponent like he was an ant trying to overcome a human all by itself. The demonic tyrant summoned meteorites, created flares, blasted out gravitational spheres, and cast curse spells.

But Javier persevered through all the hardships and fought even more valiantly. He was a sturdy toy and was never going to break despite the adversities. He showed immense willpower and put a smile on the king of hell's face.

Except it couldn't last forever.

I... shed too much blood.

Javier's breath became visibly rough as he continued to engage the enemy in an epic, transcendent battle. His stamina was being depleted slowly but surely. Even if he was a grandmaster with six circles, the grave injury on his

shoulder and a tremendous amount of blood loss weren’t easy to overcome. In fact, it was a miracle he had put up this much of a fight thus far.

Gush!

Javier bled from his left shoulder once again, as he readied himself to launch another strike. He turned pale and his movement slowed down. But the grandmaster did not stop.

Not yet.

It wasn’t over. Lloyd was still unconscious. He had to buy him more time so his unruly master could get up and run away. That was his duty as the knight.

Please.

Javier desperately wished for extra strength so he could continue standing his ground. He strengthened his resolve once again, but to no avail; the physical limits imposed on his body were merciless. The more he ran and amplified mana through the mana heart and the more he hustled with his body, his heart pounded faster, discharging more blood out from the wound.

Javier’s face became extremely pale. Even his lips were white. But the grandmaster did not stop.

Please.

He took a step forward and lifted his sword. He approached the king of hell. He drew the line in the air and swung his sword. But his movement was unfortunately way too slow and fragile.

Tap.

There was no aura on the blade. The feeble swing of the sword tapped against the king of hell’s shoulder.

“Is this all you got?”

It was the smile of blatant mockery. Javier did not verbally reply. Instead, he lifted his sword up again instinctively like when he was first learning how to fight with a sword, as he treaded between the conscious and the unconscious realm. He slowly moved his sword, but the swing could not be completed.

Bam!

The king of hell had kicked Javier in the stomach.

The grandmaster couldn’t even scream in pain. He flew back and rolled on the ground covered in blood.

“...Ugh. Huff, huff.”

He had to get up, but his body wasn’t listening to him. He crawled on the ground and placed his sword on the floor. He exerted whatever strength he could muster into his legs, but the ominous shadow was cast over him before he could. Javier lifted his chin and stared at his adversary.

“You’ve fought valiantly. I will let you serve me as the commander of hell’s knights in your death.”

The king of hell was holding the sickle in his hand. It fell on Javier’s neck diagonally. It was an attack he could neither avoid nor block. It was over. He had failed. His endeavor despite the adversity was going to end here.

As soon as Javier realized this, he internally reiterated this phrase as if these were his last words.

Master Lloyd. Please be safe.

He was truly sorry he couldn’t protect his master until the end. The cold steel fell on his neck, slicing through the air mercilessly. But a dark silhouette stood before him and obstructed his view.

Pierce!

“...!!”

Javier did not have a chance to stop this. Warm liquid was spattered on his face. This sound hadn’t come from the grandmaster, nor did the blood.

“...Master Lloyd?” He instinctively murmured.

Lloyd was standing in front of him with his chest pierced, yet with a nonchalant smile on his face.

“Stop crying, you crybaby.”

“What kind of...”

“This is all part of the plant. So stop crying.”

“But...”

“This can actually work thanks to you now.”

“Master Lloyd?”

Javier was confused. He couldn’t comprehend why Lloyd was smiling and babbling on about success when things were obviously terrible. But he did not get a chance, as Lloyd lost light in his eyes rapidly. There was no more sign of life from the mischievous smile on the face of his lord. The young master he had sworn to serve breathed his last as his head dropped. He had died.

“...No way.”

This wasn’t supposed to happen. Javier was in disbelief. He refused to believe what he saw. This was not the ending he had desired. He desperately cried out.

“Master Lloyd!”

He wished to get up on his feet so he could stretch out his hands to the deceased. He wanted to shake his body to wake him up from the slumber if possible. But it wasn’t. He couldn’t get up. He couldn’t stretch out his

hands. He couldn’t hold him and wake him up. There was nothing he could do.

Clink!

The king of hell let go of his sickle, which fell on the ground with Lloyd’s corpse on it like a skewer. The demonic ruler then stood up with a satisfactory smile on his face from the accomplishment of his ultimate goal. The grim shadow still stood as he looked down on Javier like a condescending tyrant, suggesting it was his turn next.

“I’ll skewer you with this,” said the king of hell, lifting his wand again. He grinned sinisterly as he pulled the weapon and pointed it at Javier.

But another surprise awaited them.

“I think I’ve made a discovery. Let me guess, you can’t recover from the damage inflicted by your own weapon, right?”

The sudden question from behind the king of hell grabbed their attention. Before the king of hell could respond, hands stretched from the rear and grappled on the neck and body of the king of hell. He then pulled and clasped onto him.

Pierce!

And the blade of the sickle pierced the king of hell in the chest. Lloyd showed his version of the grim smile from the evil ruler’s back.

“Finally. I was waiting for this moment.”

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Chapter 399: Farewell (1)

It did not hurt.

Lloyd inadvertently chuckled at the phrase that praised selfless behaviors.

What an outrageous bullcrap.

Lloyd maintained a nonchalant smile on his face. He genuinely thought glorifying sacrifice was absolutely absurd, after having done it himself once; he had died in someone else's place and come back to life.

Because it's really nothing.

Lloyd rubbed his chest which had been pierced by the sickle. It actually did not hurt at all. He had been overrun with fear when the king of hell swung his weapon to skewer him, but the estate developer felt nothing after coming back to life, not because of the adrenaline. It was as if he had taken pain-killing opioids for breakfast, lunch, and dinner.

Javier stared at Lloyd in absolute surprise, speechlessly. It appeared that the grandmaster was trying to think of what to say, but couldn't. Lloyd looked at the dropped jaw of his buddy and chuckled even harder.

"Surprise, ahahaha."

Pull!

Lloyd exerted more strength into his arms and pulled the king of hell closer, using the blade of the sickle protruding from his chest to carve into the evil ruler's back. It pierced the enemy in the stomach and found its way out to the front, causing the king of hell to shake from the pain. Dark demonic energy left the enemy's body, but he wasn't going to fall or kneel on the ground. Lloyd wasn't going to allow it.

"How...?"

King of hell barely managed to ask the question, putting a more apparent smile of satisfaction on Lloyd's face.

"I have the dragon king endorsement membership. One of its benefits is resurrection, and it worked."

"Th-then...!"

"Yeah. This is what I've been planning from the get-go."

More demonic energy left the demon king's body, but Lloyd grappled onto him even harder with the intent to make the enemy struggle like a bug skewered by a spike.

"Urgh...!!"

"It hurts, right? I knew it, because I read about it in *The Knight of Iron and Blood* before."

"The knight of... what?"

"You know about it. It explained the only way to deal damage to a lich."

"No way."

"Yes, way. The lich can only be damaged by its own weapon. Anything else, it could recover from thanks to its invincibility and immortality. So the only way is to take the lich's weapon and use it against the undead sorcerer."

"But how...? That's impossible!"

"It is impossible under normal circumstances because anyone that holds the lich's weapon in hand sustains incurable damage and loses sanity."

"But you.."

"I didn't."

Lloyd glanced down at the sickle that skewered both Lloyd and the king of hell. It was gruesome to look at it, but that made his smile even greater.

“Because I didn’t grab it with my hands.”

“Urgh...!”

“Don’t you dare try to push me away.”

The king of hell struggled and twitched violently, but Lloyd tightened the grasp on the enemy’s neck and ribcage. The king of hell lifted his arm to elbow Lloyd in the face.

Bam!

It was a clean hit and should have crushed Lloyd’s face. But it did not hurt at all.

“It itches.”

It didn’t even. Lloyd actually felt nothing from the strike.

Bang! Bang! Bang!

More elbow strikes fell on his face, but Lloyd chuckled again.

“Holy. The resurrection endorsed by the dragon king is amazing.”

It was indeed astounding and marvelous. Lloyd had been doubtful even though he had heard this answer from the Jewel of Truth due to how unbelievable this idea was, but it was real to have experienced it firsthand.

I can’t believe it really was speaking the truth.

Lloyd was reminded of the question he had asked the Jewel of Truth before the battle began. The artifact gave him the answer to how to defeat the king of hell, and it was precisely this.

It said the resurrection benefit from the dragon king endorsement wasn't just bringing one's life back. It's supposed to grant the resurrected absolute invulnerability and healing magic regardless of the situation, for five minutes.

Lloyd thought it made sense because the individual who resurrected through this benefit while submerged underwater would certainly drown again without any form of protection.

Drown to death, come back to life, only to drown again. That's not fair.

It was likewise for someone who died from a fire. Without protective or healing magic, one was bound to suffer again immediately.

I would suffocate from smoke right away unless I die before that from severe burns.

The five minutes of absolute protection and healing magic was the time given to the individual to get out of the tight spot. Lloyd was enjoying its benefits to the fullest.

"Urgh! Argh!"

Pow! Pow! Pow!

The king of hell wildly moved its body like a beast that had walked into a bear trap. He smacked Lloyd in the face with his elbow and the back of his own head, but Lloyd did not feel any pain thanks to the invulnerability he had been granted.

Nothing will work.

The estate developer pulled him even harder. The king of hell finally seemed to realize that his efforts were going to be meaningless.

"Urgh..."

The evil ruler grabbed the sickle that protruded from his abdomen. Lloyd realized the attempt to break the blade off, but even this move had been

anticipated.

False Swing!

Lloyd internally shouted out as he glanced at the king of hell’s attempt, prompting a pop-up message in front of his eyes.

Ding-dong!

[Mana Heart Skill Option 6: Attack Design is activated.]

[Loading False Swing data from Slot 1.]

[It will cost 250 RP to activate this option.]

[Remaining RP: 7,718]

“...What?”

The king of hell’s hands that was attempting to break the blade apart came to an abrupt pause as another message popped up.

[Target of your Attack Design is resisting.]

[He is trying to negate the movement preset by Attack Design through the amazing willpower of the mythical creature.]

[Duration of Attack Design will be reduced to 10%.]

[However, it will not matter because the duration of False Swing movement data is 0.2 seconds.]

[False Swing data from Slot 1 has been implemented in reality.]

As soon as the last message showed up, the king of hell’s hands moved forward smoothly like a skater on ice. The sharp sickle glowed.

Slash!

“Urgh!”

Four fingers except the thumb from the right hand and the thumb from the left were severed. And those fingers weren’t going to regenerate this time.

“Suho Kim! You little...!”

The king of hell shouted out in fury. Lloyd chuckled as he complimented himself for having waited for the right moment to use this attack design instead of resorting to it when he was being dominated. He grappled onto the king of hell even tighter, stirring up even more anger.

“How dare you!”

Thwoosh! Kaboom!

A nasty shockwave from dark magic was unleashed from the demon’s body, which could literally shred Lloyd apart to pieces under normal circumstances. Thanks to the effect of invulnerability, however, Lloyd was unscathed.

“How long do you think you can hold on like this for?!”

Lloyd agreed. In fact, he only had four more remaining minutes until the invulnerability effect expired. The estate developer knew he had to wrap things up before that happened.

“That’s why we’ll be walking together.”

He pulled the king of hell and walked backward, slowly but surely. The two men skewered by the same sickle moved together.

Ding-dong.

[Skill Option 3: Power Saving Mode is activated.]

[You are able to maintain the effect of the Asrahan Core Technique, albeit slightly, even when you’re absolutely fatigued.]

[Mana Amplification Rate: 25%]

Zing...

The threeway circle that barely operated provided bonus strength to the estate developer, allowing him to drag the king of hell with it. The enemy tried to resist, but perhaps he had lost too much energy from the sickle attack.

“Hmph! Do you honestly believe you can defeat me like this?!”

“Yeah. I think I can.”

“What makes you think that way?!” The king of hell shouted louder.

“Nothing in particular,” replied Lloyd with a chuckle. He had no reason to tell his enemy that, nor was he obligated; he did not want to ruin the plan now.

Lloyd continued dragging his adversary towards the intended destination consistently. It was the end of the huge platform, and the king of hell seemed to finally realize what the estate developer was trying to accomplish.

“S-Suho Kim?!”

It was the first time the king of hell ever showed this blatant frustration in his eyes.

“No way!” The evil ruler resisted and tried to turn his head.

“Yes way,” said Lloyd quickly, exerting more strength on his right arm that was holding the foe’s neck. “Just shut up and come with me.”

“H-hold on a second, Suho Kim!” The king of hell resisted even harder.

Shockwaves of dark magic were unleashed and more meteorites fell from the sky to explode the area. But Lloyd had three whole minutes before the

effects of invulnerability expired. That was enough to drag the king of hell to the intended destination and to leave his last words to Javier.

“Right, Javier?” He lifted his head and looked at Javier, who was trying his best to crawl his way here. He was staring at Lloyd like he wanted to stop him, but it seemed that his strength was failing him. Javier was desperate, but couldn’t due to the lack of energy. This put a smile on Lloyd’s face.

“I know, I know. I hate to do this too. I really despised this method, so I tried to see if I could beat this enemy in other ways.”

But all else had failed. Lloyd knew he should have resorted to this from the start. He regretted having taken his allies all the way here to make them suffer.

“But this is the only way. Nothing else will work.”

Javier’s lips trembled. Lloyd noticed that the grandmaster was calling out to him. He could see, hear, and feel his buddy’s heart. But there was no turning back.

“This is the right thing to do. The more I try to hold on, persevere, and fight through it all, the more sufferings that seem to fall on the people around me. I can’t bear that.”

Lloyd chuckled bitterly. In truth, he wanted to enjoy the fruits of his labor in the Frontera Estate and spend more time with his friends and allies, whom he had come to rely on. He wanted to lead an ordinary and unremarkable life with them. But Lloyd had realized even that was too much to hope for. It was greed.

“I wanted to deny it as much as I could at first. Who wouldn’t? I want to live luxuriously like anybody else. But the more I thought about it, the more I realized that even if I overcame the most imminent problem, the enforced fate phenomenon would occur again and... I don’t think I can keep doing this forever.”

Even if he were to slay the king of hell here and resolve this problem, another restoration of enforced destiny would take place, putting everyone in danger all over again. It was going to be a greater and more severe catastrophe because the previous one fell short.

“I really can’t. I’m scared now. I don’t think I can do this anymore. All this is happening because of me. I can’t put the count and the countess, you, or everyone else in peril just to make my dreams come true.”

Lloyd dragged the king of hell harder and continued walking.

“So this is really it. If I have to really choose between you and me for this to end once and for all, I choose to banish myself from this world. After all, you really belong to this realm whereas I don’t. I came from elsewhere. I am an outsider. This all happened because of my stubbornness and unwillingness to cease to exist.”

Lloyd’s eyes became red, even without him realizing it. But he still maintained the smile on his face to put his friend's mind a bit at ease. It was to make him feel a little less guilty.

“That’s why I must tell you this. Please tell my queen that I was genuinely delighted by her proposal. I was so grateful. That I am so sorry for leaving like this. And I really enjoyed my journey with you. This has been the best part of my life, away from the moldy and smelly, tiny room I spent most of my time in. I really, really had a lot of fun.”

Lloyd couldn’t tell if it was him or Javier who was shedding tears. His vision was blurry.

“Thank you so much for spending time with me. I really don’t regret it one bit, because this has been a great ride. You, and everyone else will remember me. I won’t ask you to think about me every given opportunity, but as long as you do every now and again, I’ll still be alive in your memories.”

Lloyd wanted to live in their memories, and that was going to be enough. He was willing to finally give up on the false hope and preposterous

dreams. He was fortunate enough to spend a few years with some of the best people he'd ever met.

The greatest estate developer pulled the king of hell with even more strength, dragging him to the end of the platform. The king of hell resisted and shouted, but Lloyd couldn't make sense of what he said. It was too late.

The portal to rebirth swirled behind him. And the greatest estate developer jumped into it, holding his arch-nemesis.

"Goodbye."

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Chapter 400: Farewell (2)

Hi. This is Lloyd... I mean, Suho Kim. You're probably wondering what I'm talking about, but this is the truth. In fact, I should have revealed this a long time ago.

The hands of Count Frontera shook as he picked up the letter containing a message left in familiar handwriting. It was that of a man who gave his hundred and ten percent before leaving the estate for good.

If, by any chance, you wouldn't get to read this message, then it would mean my alternative plan has worked and I have returned home. However, if you're reading this message, I wouldn't be there. There is no exception to anyone behind the gate of rebirth, including the king of hell.

The countess dropped her head as the count hugged her by her shoulders. Their eyes shook constantly as they continued.

I should have told you this before, but I lacked the courage. That is why I reveal this truth to you right now through a letter. I was a coward. I am so sorry. I mean it.

The count let out a huge sigh at the last sentence. He thought Lloyd did not have a reason to apologize. If there was someone that had to feel sorry, it was they. Count Frontera felt no words could express his gratitude towards Lloyd properly.

"Honey."

The countess glanced at the count, who nodded in response before reading the letter again.

My real name is Suho Kim, born and raised in Seoul. I lived in a tiny room just enough to lie down in that city. I honestly have no idea how and why I became Lloyd Frontera. I just... woke up in his body one day.

The count continued onto the next page.

I was flustered and perplexed in the beginning. So I lied. I pretended to be your real son Lloyd Frontera. I blamed the fate for being so cruelly mischievous with this move, and thought it really wasn't my fault. Well, that's what I told myself each day. This lie built up until I ran into the real Lloyd.

The count and the countess were visibly shaken.

He had become an apparition and was wandering around in the underworld after losing his body over to me. That was when I realized that nothing would change the fact he suffered because of me, even if it was unintended and accidental. It hurt, but I tried to appear nonchalant on the surface. I did not want to be disgusted by my own hypocrisy.

The hands shook as Suho's confession continued.

So I did everything in my power to help him. Thankfully, he entered through the portal of rebirth. I have no idea what he was reincarnated into, or to which parents; I am so sorry I don't have more information. But he did ask me this: to take care of you two and tell you what became of him. Perhaps this is why I'm writing this letter immediately before the final battle begins.

And it went on.

I won't try to cover it up. I am so sorry for hiding behind written words instead of telling you this in person like a coward. But there should be a set of huge plans stored in my bedroom closet. Those are construction plans to be put to use after the battle is over, from the dam at Lake Kapua, waterworks and sewage by the mountain range, and drainage at Maritz Farmlands. I also added how to construct stabilization piles and anchors to be installed on the slopes of Namaran, as well as how and where to place them.

Lloyd had thought about the work to be done on the estate until the very end, even in the writing that could well become his last words.

But everything will be alright even in my absence, because our engineering corp is so skilled now. Perhaps I made the last message unnecessarily long

and wasted your time. I apologize once again. Please explain well to Julian and Javier, as well as Her Majesty. Please take good care of Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, Bibeong, and Ggoming. They're all good kids. Farewell, my... father and mother. Thank you for everything.

The count shed tears silently as the countess covered her face in her husband's clothes. Javier bit his lips tightly in frustration.

"That's all I found in Master Lloyd's bedroom."

"I see."

"..."

"Sir Javier Asrahan," said the count.

"Yes, my lord."

"You've been with him the entire time, wherever he went."

"I did, my lord."

"Then... did you sort of have an idea about it as well?"

"...Please forgive me, my lord."

"No need. You probably had faith that he would eventually tell us in person. Isn't that right?"

Javier had, and that was why it broke his heart even more. The grandmaster had never imagined in his wildest dreams Lloyd would resort to such a method—sacrificing himself to drag the enemy into the gate of rebirth. Javier regretted and blamed himself for having failed to anticipate Lloyd's plan. Had he had just a little more strength, he would have been able to stop Lloyd. Javier would have jumped to the other side of the portal with the king of hell in his master's stead.

But he couldn't. Despite having sworn to protect the fake Lloyd regardless of the adversities plenty of times, he relied on Lloyd's selfless act instead.

He couldn’t save him. He could only watch his last moments with his eyes.

Javier still did not say anything because he figured the count and the countess must have been devastated even more than he. Displaying sadness in front of them was like a pretense by an incompetent knight who had failed to protect someone he was sworn to. So he told himself not to shed tears. He strengthened his resolve not to be shaken by this.

I do not deserve to.

He was going to endure the pain. The agony he was going to suffer was a way to pay for the sins he had committed.

“If you’ll excuse me, my lord, I’ll be on standby.”

“Yeah. You may leave.”

Javier quickly ran away from the count and countess’s presence before a flood of tears burst out, and heard the wailing cries of the countess and the consoling, yet shaky voice of the count behind closed doors. The count told his wife that Lloyd had been a good kid, and he was like a gift from the heavens. He assured his wife that they had to remember him the way he was, and that was the only way to repay him for all the good things he had done. The grandmaster walked away through the hallway with a heavy heart.

He let out a deep sigh. Javier thought the refreshing air of the night sky would put him a bit more at ease, but it didn’t. Wherever he went and whatever he looked at, including the starry sky, his heart was still broken. The grandmaster continued to sigh and walk until he reached a certain grave that was freshly made. He glanced at the new gravestone that was still not covered in moss and only then realized where he had come from.

“You’re here, Sir Javier Asrahan.”

“...Your Majesty.”

Queen Alicia was standing in front of the grave with a bitter smile on her face.

“No need to pay pointless respect in a situation like this. Not here anyways. This area does not belong to me but to this fool.”

She stared at the gravestone on which the phrase Javier never wished to see was etched: *Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of Count Frontera and faithful vassal and key contributor to the Magentano Dynasty, sleeps here.*

It was strange. It was peculiar. It was even surreal. Javier felt like this gravestone was all a lie. Perhaps it was because he wanted to deny the harsh reality.

“What of your injuries?”

“I am recovering, thanks to your grace.”

“Good.”

“Your grace knows—“

“Enough.”

Javier wondered if the queen was crying. It seemed that way, as Her Majesty was looking down on the ground with shaky shoulders and clenched fists. It was perhaps due to the words Javier was about to speak, which reminded her of the man who had always reiterated phrases like “Your grace knows no bounds,” and “Please forgive me” with a nonchalant smile on his face.

“I’ll be on standby by the knight’s quarter.”

Javier did not want to interrupt the queen’s moment with his master. He quickly got away from the grave like he was a runaway, and walked restlessly without a particular destination. He harbored the emptiness in his heart and just went on, just like that day when he had done just this with Lloyd. He remembered when Lloyd had asked him about Javier’s father and

what kind of man he was. Except he was alone this time, causing him to chuckle bitterly.

“Ha.”

This was why Javier disliked the night; it wetted his face. The grandmaster blamed the night mist as he recalled the moments he regretted. He missed him.

Master Lloyd...

Javier wondered what had happened to the man he failed to protect after jumping into the portal of rebirth. He became curious about what kind of life he was given as a result. He wanted to know if Lloyd managed to find a new life that was mediocre, unremarkable, and happy with just enough wealth not to worry about things. The grandmaster desperately wished this as he walked, until he stopped somewhere and jumped into the water.

His shoulder covered in bandages hurt excruciatingly, but he did not care. He dove deeper and deeper to the very bottom of the lake, at which the Jewel of Truth stood. He then placed his hand on the altar, just like how the fake Lloyd had done some time ago.

[You, who wish to obtain a truthful answer from the Jewel of Truth. You must reveal a secret about yourself, that only you are aware of, to this world in exchange for the truth you seek.]

The voice resounded in his head as expected, and the knight did not hesitate to give his answer.

I never, ever thought once about the life with Master Lloyd, and even right now.

And the response was immediate.

[You have willingly shared a secret that only you had been aware of, as the price to acquire the truth you seek.]

The surface of the lake glowed as the night sky became bright. Javier asked again.

What happened to Suho Kim's soul after entering through the gate of rebirth?

Javier wanted to know. He wanted to hear a good response. After a brief moment of waiting that felt like an eternity, the Jewel finally answered.

[Suho Kim's soul did not find a new body despite having jumped into the portal of rebirth.]

What?

Javier flinched inadvertently as the jewel continued.

[Instead of being reincarnated into a new body, he went back into the original body of Suho Kim, staying at Room 301 of the tiny complex in Seoul of the different dimension from which he hailed.]

What...?

It was absolutely astonishing and unprecedented.

Then what of his memories about this place? Us?"

Javier quickly asked, and was able to hear a response.

[He retailed full memory of what transpired here in the estate and dearly misses all of you. It is possible to bring him back to this realm if you can travel across the dimensions.]

Javier's heart pounded in excitement from the pleasant surprise. It was an unexpected answer.

Let me ask one more...but I will reveal something first. I am actually ecstatic, thinking about Suho Kim and what became of him.

The Jewel of Truth spoke again.

[You have willingly shared a secret that only you had been aware of, as the price to acquire the truth you seek.]

The water’s surface and the sky above it glowed brightly again. Javier wasted no time.

Where is the dragon king Verkis?

Javier knew he could travel across dimensions. With his help, bringing Suho Kim, the fake Lloyd, back to this realm was a possibility. They could return to their normal lives without worrying about anything anymore.

Please...

The grandmaster’s desperate plea did not go unheard, as the jewel responded.

[Dragon king Verkis has taken over the lair of another dragon Atrox, which is located in the topmost peak of the Cuantara Mountains, and is taking a nap in that dark pit.]

Cuantara Mountains wasn’t too far away, fortunately. Javier immediately swam up to the surface upon hearing the answer and headed straight into the lord’s mansion, slamming open the doors to the other Lloyd’s bedroom.

“Sir Ggoming, and everyone else.”

“Ggoming?”

“Ppodong?”

“Bangul?”

“Hamang?”

Sir Ppodong, Sir Bangul, Sir Hamang, and Sir Ggoming, all of whom had been depressed by the disappearance of their master, turned around and glanced at Javier.

“I found a way to resurrect... I mean, bring Master Lloyd back to this place. Please come with me.”

“Ppodong?”

“Bangul?”

“Hamang?”

“Ggoming?”

“We don’t have a lot of time,” said Javier, hurrying the beasts while taking out the red sunflower seed to feed Sir Ggoming before hopping onto the enlarged creature with the rest. “We must head south. Now!”

“G-Ggoming!”

Ggoming did not comprehend what was going on, but Javier pushed it forward anyway. The winged summoned flew towards the south, away from the estate to the Cuantara Mountains, past other ranges, plains, and rivers. In a few hours, they saw the entrance to the dragon lair in the highest peak of the mountain range just like the Jewel of Truth had revealed.

Javier took the rest into the pit. It was as expected of the dragon’s lair, full of deadly traps. But the grandmaster did not care; he valiantly fought through and broke everything by force, even running across a black dragon, presumed to be the original owner of this lair, knocked unconscious by an external blunt force. After passing through a series of otherwise perilous situations, Javier finally found what he came looking for.

The old manticore, which had been lying down like a faithful dog waiting for his owner to wake up, turned around and saw the grandmaster. Javier then noticed the dragon king Verkis sound asleep next to the loyal beast.

“Please excuse me, good manticore,” said Javier, approaching the dragon king.

“Grr?”

“This has to do with ensuring the safe return of Lloyd Frontera, whom the dragon king has been sponsoring.”

“Grr? Grr!”

Perhaps the old manticore had read Javier’s desperate mind, as the beast willingly stepped aside. Javier walked closer to the dragon king and spoke.

“Great Dragon King Verkis. Please wake up.”

“...Zzz.”

“Please. Just one moment of your time is enough.”

“...Zzz.”

“There is something I must discuss.”

“...Zzz.”

“...”

Javier knew it wasn’t going to work. He reached out his hand and shook the dragon king by his shoulders.

“It’s an important matter about the individual that you have been sponsoring.”

Javier shook the dragon king lightly at first but had to exert more and more strength eventually and gradually. But the dragon king did not budge an inch, despite all the shaking, and even shouting into his ears. Javier realized that he wasn’t going to wake up through normal means.

“...”

There was only one way he could think of: cause an even more intense pressure than by shaking him or shouting in his ears, to make sure he woke up.

Zing!

Javier activated his six-way circle and unsheathed his sword, with the intent to slice the dragon king’s head.

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Chapter 401: Glorious and Gratifying (1)

Strange noise resounded within my head on the other side of the gate of rebirth. The king of hell was surely making it worse by grumbling so much.

Ugh. I'm tired.

I frowningly rolled over on my bed in fatigue. I was exhausted, and rightly so; I had led the alliance soldiers in battle, drowning a corp of hell's knights before facing the king of hell in an epic fight in which he gave everything. It was almost the result of karma striking back, as I had dragged the evil ruler of the underworld into the portal of rebirth with me.

But I succeeded in the end.

It was absolutely the last resort I had in my mind and the only method that worked according to the Jewel of Truth. I barely managed to even pull it off, but it worked. I had a genuinely satisfactory smile on my face from the feeling of achievement, but it did not last long.

"...Moving onto today's forecast."

An unfamiliar voice characterized by eloquence spoke out.

I must be dreaming.

I suspected it came from the dream and rolled to the other side. However, that peculiar voice continued to speak.

"Dressing in warm clothes is definitely recommended, as the Siberian High of early winter has carried some cold air from the north. The temperature in Seoul fell to fifteen degrees this morning--"

Huh...?

I wasn't dreaming. The voice was surely coming from next to me.

But how?

I realized something hadn’t gone according to the plan. I clearly passed the gate of rebirth and was supposed to go through an after-death process like choosing from a selection of new lives to lead. But I was hearing the news report on today’s weather.

I opened my eyes in curiosity and froze to the spot immediately.

“...The presence of strong wind will make it feel even colder and the temperature will drop to an annual low during the weekend.”

The television was the only thing that emanated light in a dark room. I could see the serious look on the face of someone dressed in an outfit that was as clean and neat as her manner of speech.

“News...?” I mumbled inadvertently.

The reporters sharing the weather forecast through the news channel would look like that. She elegantly smiled as she added, as if she had just heard me and was responding.

“Snow flurries may fall in the northern Gangwon Province in the mountainside, with high waves out in the sea.”

It felt as though an avalanche was falling in my heart.

“What the hell’s going on?” I complained without even realizing it.

“...from weather forecast for today. Thank you.”

I closed my lips as the old, barely working television let out delightful music to mark the ending of the news. It certainly looked familiar. It made me feel nauseous. I was shaking my two hands in frustration when I recognized the television I had in the tiny room back in Seoul. I was in that very place again.

What the...?

I wondered why I was back in this place. It drove me out of my mind; I looked around restlessly like an unstable person, failing to look at a single

spot as I got reminded of the familiar odor of mold and saw the yellowed walls and soggy bed sheets and blanket.

An old cell phone with a cracked screen lay next to my pillow. I was in disbelief and denial as I turned on the cell phone and checked today's date. I tossed the device on the bed as soon as I verified it and went straight outside.

"Ugh..." *Blergh.*

I felt extremely nauseous. I had to go to the public bathroom and empty my stomach. I then noticed my own face in the mirror.

My face was yellowed from the lack of proper nutrition, not to mention the bags underneath my eyes from chronic fatigue. My lips were dry and my hair was unkempt. I was tearing up.

I was asking myself who I was, why I was here, and why today's date indicated it was the morning after the day in which I had found myself in Lloyd's body.

This can't be. Can it?

Tears dripped down my cheeks against my will. I couldn't comprehend all this, because I had clearly jumped into the gate of rebirth, carrying the king of hell in my arms. I was supposed to be given a new life and opportunity. I was appalled by the realization that I had returned to the life in the tiny room, which I dreaded the most, and the morning after the day I left this wretched place as I found myself in the body of Lloyd Frontera, no less.

Come on. This is unfair.

I was sad and upset. I didn't know what I was so furious about, but I was.

Crush!

I inadvertently threw a punch at my own face in the reflection, cracking the mirror and leaving a scar on my own fist. But it did not hurt. I was too frustrated to feel the physical pain.

“Ha. Haha. Ha.”

There was nothing else I could do except laugh bitterly. I was way too devastated. It was too overwhelming.

***

I did not know how I spent my morning. I couldn’t process all this, save for the fact that I had definitely returned to the body of Suho Kim.

I picked up my cell phone as I lay down powerlessly and noticed three missed calls that came in the morning. I didn’t have to check to know who had called.

They were probably wondering if I wasn’t coming to work.

I then recalled the incident that transpired several years ago, and the construction site I used to work at until immediately before I found myself in Lloyd Frontera’s body. But that happened just yesterday in this timeline. I genuinely wondered if all that had just been an extremely long and realistic dream: from endeavoring to make it happen and toiling under the sun, to enjoying spending time with others and overcoming all those hardships in the Frontera Estate, the royal capital of Magenta, and in the continent of Lorasia.

Javier... and my queen.

I also remembered the count and the countess, as well as Julian, not to mention Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, Bibeong, and Ggoming. The faces of everyone with whom I came into contact while I spent time in the body of Lloyd Frontera came up in my head, as well as the memories of such. That was what made it even more devastating and agonizing.

I was overwhelmed with fear, but there was something I wanted to check. So I turned on the novel app on my phone and looked at the list of series I had read. I found *The Knight of Blood and Iron* and tapped it open, wondering if my life as Lloyd Frontera had been reflected in the story to

change its contents. I hoped to see the traces of my endless efforts and the delightful yet arduous events I had experienced. I was scared but excited.

But that excitement turned to disappointment and fear of misery in no time.

There was none. I couldn't find a single trace of myself and what I had done in any part of the story. Lloyd Frontera died in the beginning, as well as the count and the countess. Javier left the estate and began his long journey to become the knight of blood and iron. The entire series was still about the epic story of this man. It was as if all I had done as Lloyd never transpired, or it was all just a dream.

No. No way.

I couldn't accept it. I put on the old parka jacket and left the tiny room and got on the subway, still in denial. Perhaps some were bothered by the presence of a man who seemed out of it, but I did not care. There was only one thing that I had in my mind.

Namsan.

I wondered if there would be traces of what I did there. There had to be.

Because I was there with Javier before.

Lloyd had gone there to find the last remaining key material required for the construction of Jewel of Truth. I recalled revisiting Seoul and hiking in Namsan, after being transported here through dragon king Verkis's dimensional drift spell. A part of the fence on which couples left locks to pray their love would last forever, was the material I was looking for. I had taken it back to the other realm.

There must be a trace. A new fence must have been installed to replace the missing one.

There had to be a part that was newer than others, with visibly less rust or blemishes.

That's all I gotta find.

Then I was going to know for sure I really visited this place with Javier, and that it wasn't a dream. That was the evidence that I had really experienced what I did.

Please.

Even if I couldn't go back to the Frontera Estate, I desperately wished for the events to have been real. Nothing was going to devastate me more than to find out that it was all just a dream.

Please.

I hiked in Namsan with desperation, passing by a crowd of people as I panted and panted. I finally got to Namsan Tower and checked out the fence, praying to find what I came looking for. But it wasn't there.

"...Huh?"

There was no such thing as an unrusted, or new fence. Each of the fences was just as old as the one next to it, still carrying the locks left by couples throughout the years. All I could see was the smiles on the faces of people as they giggled romantically.

There was no trace of my visit along with Javier. No evidence could prove that my memories from the past few years were real.

"...So it never happened."

There was no such thing from the start. It was all a dream: a realistically grand one, that made deceived me into believing it had been real. It was so sweet and gratifying that I had mistakenly thought it was true. That was it.

"Ha. Haha..."

I could only laugh bitterly in defeat. I walked powerlessly down the hill and passed through another crowd of happy people. Couples, friends, and family were giggling together in joy as I walked down the stairs all alone. I didn't know where I was going. I only walked restlessly and wandered, with the glimpse of hope I couldn't let go of, that Javier would start bantering

with me. That the queen would smile at me and ask for a spar. I stopped walking and placed my hands in the inner pocket of my old parka jacket, but there was no Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, Bibeong, or Ggoming. I couldn't feel the presence of the skeleton corp or Draggy. I did not have the mana heart or the circle.

"Ha..."

The sudden, empty laughter by someone wandering like a madman was perhaps a strange sight for others. They gave me dirty stares, but it did not matter. I continued enduring the sharp, cold breeze that made me cough throughout the afternoon until I returned to my tiny room in the evening. My stupid, obnoxious stomach growled, without realizing it wasn't its place to butt in. That was when I realized this.

I didn't eat anything today.

I haven't drunk any water, either. I was starving. I checked my pockets and found two thousand won and spent 1,500 won to buy myself a roll of gimbap from the eatery on the first floor of the building. I was on my way up to the small room when a familiar, yet not very encouraging voice called out to me.

"Room 301."

The superintendent of the building was out in the hallway.

"Why did you break the mirror in the bathroom this morning? Others told me it was your doing," asked the superintendent with a frown on their face.

I did not reply. I only stared at the super blankly, until I was met with a sighing response.

"What the hell is up with you? Enough is enough. Isn't it about time you realized you can't cause inconveniences for others like this?"

"I'm sorry."

“Sorry isn’t going to cut it. You don’t live here alone. You should have reported right away if you broke the mirror. And when are you going to pay your rent for this month? It’s been past due for days. And you still had the money to buy yourself a meal?”

The superintendent tapped my bag of food twice and continued.

“While we’re at it, I know that bowls of rice and kimchi are complimentary with the rent here, but don’t you think you’re abusing our kindness when you’re not even paying your rent? How long do you plan to keep using the same excuse that you didn’t get paid on time?”

“...I’m so sorry.”

“You should be. Pay your rent, and I’m also going to bill you for the mirror repair cost. Have I made myself clear?”

“Yeah.”

I quickly moved away from the superintendent’s dirty look and got into my tiny room, which I could fill easily just by lying down on the floor. The moldy wallpapers welcomed me back in, as I let out a heavy sigh.

“Ha.”

I wasn’t even mad. I thought about arguing back, but I did not feel like it. I could only laugh bitterly like this and sigh. I took off the old parka jacket and sat on the bed, convincing myself that it was not a big deal. But I couldn’t. I didn’t understand why.

Gosh.

It was devastating. I couldn’t accept the fact that all this had just been an extremely realistic dream. It was so upsetting to acknowledge it. Everything I’d worked so hard for came crumbling down in an instant, and I didn’t have the desire or the strength to go on anymore. The fact that I had returned to the hopeless life of Suho Kim withering away in a tiny room full

of mold slapped me across the face. It hurt. I was shedding tears without realizing it.

Knock. Knock.

Someone knocked on the door. I wondered if the super came back to bicker at me about the mirror again.

What this time?

I quickly wiped the tears off my face and tried to act nonchalant as best as I could. I strengthened my resolve not to show my weak side over and over again, as I slowly opened the door.

“...Huh?”

And he was there. The man that I missed so much, because of the realization I could never get to see him again, was standing right outside the door. He was looking straight at me through teary eyes, with a hint of joy on his face.

“...I missed you so much, Master Lloyd,” said Javier with a huge, tearful smile.

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Chapter 402: Glorious and Gratifying (2)

“I really wanted to see you in those.”

“Did you really?”

“Yeah, however.”

“However?”

“You look even more terrible than I imagined.”

“Hey. What do you mean terrible?”

Javier’s cruel analysis of the state I was in irritated me. I questioned on what basis he would make such a claim, but the grandmaster’s response was even colder. He walked to the corner of the groom’s room and picked up the full body mirror and carried it this way. And I looked at the reflection of myself dressed in the white tuxedo with a bright smile on my face.

“See? I look just fine,” I fixed my posture in front of the mirror and looked back pompously. But Javier’s response was not positive.

“Whew. You certainly would have looked a lot better in your previous body.”

“...”

“And a lot more proportional.”

“...Dude.”

“And a lot less disturbing to look at.”

“Hey.”

“Yeah.”

“Let’s be real. Don’t I honestly look better than when I was in my previous body?”

“No. Never.”

“You’re just refusing to admit it. If you examine the features carefully--“

“I see the resemblances here and there, but you’ve definitely gotten uglier in detail,” said Javier in the coldest fashion yet with a serious look on his face. “To compare, your previous face was like a potato.”

“And what about now?”

“An identified object that resembles a potato.”

“You’re fired.”

“Seriously?”

“Of course.”

“For real?”

“Yeah.”

“Do you mean it?”

“Why do you keep asking the same question?”

“Jeez. I know I should never have brought you back from that tiny room of yours.”

“I chose to come back, dude.”

“...”

“Because you desperately begged for me to return, explaining how it was impossible to go on without me. The estate would be in shambles, the skeletal corp wouldn’t listen, and things would just be in horrific shape.

Master Lloyd, please come back and rectify things again! was what you said. Wasn't it?"

"Did somebody smack you hard in the back of the head?"

"No."

"Strange. You don't seem to have a fever either."

"I'm perfectly fine."

"Perhaps the anxiety and nervousness about the marriage has messed your rationale and memories up."

"I'm not that anxious or nervous."

"Except you've been sweating profusely for some time."

I became speechless because Javier was actually spot on. I plopped on the chair in the waiting room, letting out a sigh.

"Ugh. I really did not expect to be married off to Her Majesty without a chance to process anything, within two weeks after I returned."

I was being honest this time. I recalled the incident that transpired two weeks ago when I was crying all by myself behind closed doors while trying to munch on the only meal I had for the entire day, drowning slowly but surely in the bottomless lake of despair and hopelessness. That was when Javier appeared and stretched out his hand of salvation. He took me back to the Frontera Estate.

I did have my share of concerns about returning, however. It was the phenomenon of enforced destiny being restored. I was genuinely afraid of the curse that might haunt me again, but it did not take me long to shake these worries off.

Because Lloyd Frontera's body has gone through the gate of rebirth and is no more. Because I'm here as Suho Kim.

The tragic fate did not enforce itself on me again. The dreadful curse had been lifted finally.

Although I no longer have the mana heart or the circle since I am in my original body.

But I still had the RP, CP, title, and measurement and engineering skills with me, not to mention greater respect and love shown by everyone.

The first people that rushed to greet me back to the estate were...

“How goes the preparation, my son?”

“...Huh?”

The voice awoke me from the moment of reminiscing. When I looked, the count and the countess were inside the waiting room.

“Father?”

“Yeah. Your father is here. What were you daydreaming about?”

“Oh, it’s nothing.”

I felt the heat on my face from embarrassment, realizing I had just called the count “Father” inadvertently.

Ugh. This is awkward.

Immediately upon my return back to the estate two weeks ago, the count and the countess had given me the warmest hug ever. I’ve decided to call them my father and mother since then. They had told me that even though they discovered everything and found out that I wasn’t Lloyd, they did not care and were grateful that I helped the real Lloyd’s soul pass through the gate of rebirth. They appreciated all I had done for the estate and had already accepted me as their own child a while ago. They told me that while embracing my wet cheeks and drooping shoulders.

“I suppose I’m a little bit nervous because this all happened really fast before I had a chance to sit and process everything in my head.”

“But rest assured,” said the countess, my mother, as she tapped me on my shoulders and glanced at my father. “I felt the same way on the day of my wedding with this man. I was so nervous and out of it. Weren’t you as well?”

“Haha, was I? I think I was calm and poised if I remember correctly.”

“But you dropped the ring while you were putting it on my finger.”

“Oh. That.”

“And you almost put it on my toe instead because you were so nervous.”

Father was defeated, just like that. Mother put a smile on her face and spoke to me again.

“Anyway. You should feel a bit more at ease. Her Majesty is so gracious towards you.”

“That’s true. But I really did not expect her to hold the sword-fighting contest as she had said.”

Honestly speaking, it was a terrifying contest. The first thing my queen said the moment we reunited with one another two weeks ago was appalling and frightening enough.

You are terribly fragile, now that I think about it. How can you call yourself a man, if you get bullied and pushed around by the king of hell like that, before dying without much resistance?

That was what she stated, looking straight into my eyes.

This won’t do. The more I think about it, the more I realize I can’t leave a feeble man like you all alone. It’s about time I did something to find you a spouse that could protect you for the rest of your life, she had added.

I will thus hold a contest of might, in which all female citizens of my kingdom could participate. The mightiest female warrior in the kingdom staying by your side to keep you safe—that would put my mind at ease, so she had continued.

Of course I will compete myself as a contestant. And I will do my absolute best, she had reassured.

And the outcome was so obvious. It was so blatantly one-sided throughout the tournament. My queen defeated all challengers that came her way and declared the moment she seized the trophy, dragging me towards her. She proclaimed that no one who harms this man would be forgiven: that her blade of ire would execute the perpetrator immediately.

That was just yesterday.

"...Ugh. And the wedding, just the next day."

My queen was indeed a woman of zero patience. But I couldn't dare stop her from proceeding with it, because I feared I could actually be kidnapped and taken away to the royal capital.

"Her Majesty clearly favors you. You must accept her kindness with gratitude."

"Very well. It's not like I'm dissatisfied about it, anyways."

"Do you mean it?"

"Yeah, if I'm completely honest."

I smiled at my father. And it was true. The people I thought about the most were Javier and my queen, throughout the day on which I returned to the tiny, moldy room in Seoul and withered away in despair. Javier was like a brother to me, with whom I spent the most time, and I hadn't had a chance to share my true feelings for my queen.

I felt extremely sorry. I regretted. I had been drenched in sorrow.

That was why I was genuinely happy for today despite the nervousness and anxiety. The second phase of my life was going to be side-by-side with someone who could face a hell's knight and come up victorious, but I was truly excited. The blessings of the people I knew added to the joy.

Shriek! "My friend Lloyd is different! His eyes, nose, and mouth became weirdly handsome!" *Shriek!*

The entrance to the groom's waiting room became crowded. I noticed the orc Arosh waving at me with his canine teeth shining so brightly, and the elf chief Moira next to him delivering the polite greetings.

"Congratulations. I was a bit surprised by your new outward appearance, but you are who you are."

"...Well, thanks."

"Don't pay too much attention to your looks, because what really matters is the inside."

"Uh, okay."

"Besides, you are now blessed with a spouse that truly cares about your character instead of your looks."

I wanted to burst out in anger at the elf for speaking the harsh truth while sugarcoating it as words of encouragement, but I could only inadvertently shed tears.

"You look so funny in that outfit, big bro," said the familiar voice in a mischievous tone.

Julian was trying his absolute best to hold his laughter in. Next to him was Lady Scheherazade, who was clearly nearing her due. And that wasn't the end of the parade by visitors.

"...Mermaid?"

"Whoa. Look at all those muscles."

“Her abs are... perfect.”

The mermaid queen showed up amidst the praises of everyone in the vicinity, as well as the centauri chieftain grabbing people’s attention with his wild full-body tattoo and the clacking noises of the horseshoes. Angel of Thrones Raphael’s fiery ring blazed even more intensely, as the hell’s knight Sir Giolexius and the skeleton corp made creaking noises of their bones.

But not all visitors were here to congratulate me. Someone was making a challenging demand right on the spot.

“Alright, when are you going to set me up with a blind date as you promised?”

Solitas had found his way into the waiting room, passing through the crowd of visitors. The young red dragon was clearly agitated by the lack of fulfillment as he asked.

“You promised to set me up with a beautiful female dragon after the battle. Why are you getting married before me, when you were supposed to introduce someone to me first?”

“Ahahaha...”

I could only sweat nervously. I knew not what to say because I had actually lied about the blind date. It was a card I played out of desperation because the situation was extremely dire. I had been thinking of looking for someone after the grand battle against the king of hell.

“I really had no idea I was going to get married so quickly like this.”

“Having had no idea isn’t going to suffice.”

Solitas grumbled and I felt the sorrow of someone that stayed single for a thousand years in my bones. I was only saved by the intervention of an unlikely savior.

“Excuse me. Are you the human Lloyd Frontera, set to marry another human Alicia Termina Magentano?”

“...Huh?”

A young woman had silently approached me and asked me a peculiar question with a smile on her face.

“Are you the human Lloyd Frontera... I mean Suho Kim?”

“I am. Who might you be...?”

“Me?”

“Yeah.”

I couldn’t tell. I had never seen a young woman with wavy, pink hair that seemed to have just become an adult. The answer was even more unexpected.

“I came here because my brother sent me.”

“Your brother?”

“Dragon king Verkis.”

“Oh,” I got up from my chair immediately and prostrated to show respect. “Uhm... How should I address you, my lady?”

“Ggo... never mind. Call me Flores.”

“It’s a pleasure. But what brings you all the way here, by the way?”

“What else would I be here for? I’m here to congratulate you on your marriage. My brother supports you, so he was supposed to be here but... that lazy bum is taking a nap again. No wonder my sister-in-law always nags at him. So I came in his stead.”

“I-I see.”

“Here. A gift for you.”

“Huh?”

“Take it.”

Flores, the younger sister of dragon king Verkis, snapped her fingers at me.

“Long life without any illnesses.”

“...Huh?”

“You defeated the former king of hell, and the underworld voted in a new, more diligent, and competent ruler. So you kinda deserve a good reward for your deeds. Goodbye, then.”

Flores, the dragon king’s sister, chuckled and left for the garden outside of the waiting room. I caught a glimpse of five beasts that seemed to have accompanied her.

“Grr... Grrr!”

“Creak. Creak!”

“Cawww!!”

“Dadadak. Dadak.”

“Badumtss. Badumtss.”

Old manticore, living armor with a soul, gargoyle, flaming salamander, and a huge ice golem were engaged in a conversation with my summons.

“Ppodong! Ppodong!”

“Bangul! Bangul!”

“Hamang! Hamang!”

“Bibeong! Bibeong!”

“Ggoming! Ggoming!”

“Grr. Creak. Caw! Dadak! Badumtss!”

“Ppodong! Bangul! Hamang! Bibeong! Ggoming!”

“G! C! C! D! B!”

“P! B! H! B! G!”

The strange conversation between five monstrous beasts and special summons covered the entire wedding hall with noise, in the midst of which Flores disappeared without a trace.

“...Forget about the blind date,” said the red dragon Solitas, who had just been harassing me with the demand.

“Huh?”

“Issue settled,” said he, chasing after Flores with a blank look on his face.

I couldn’t believe how unfortunate the red dragon was, because he clearly seemed to have fallen for the younger sister of the dragon king.

...I wouldn’t go after that woman if I were you.

I could see a series of proper beatings by the dragon king, but that thought soon subsided. I had to care about my own safety.

“Why do you tremble like a leaf?”

“...Your Majesty?”

The only non-visitor in this establishment today was standing right in front of me, wearing a white bride’s dress with a mysterious smile on her face.

“Hmm. I think I get it. The marriage with me must have been so exciting and ecstatic for you.”

“O-of course it is. Except...”

“Except?”

“Aren’t we supposed to not see each other before the actual wedding ceremony?”

“We’re not?”

“Uh, yes, actually--“

“Because of the superstition that forbids the groom from seeing the bride in the wedding dress before the ceremony?”

“...”

“I knew it.”

“Your Majesty.”

“It’s really okay,” said my queen with a consoling smile on her face. “No superstition would get in the way today, because I decided so. Anyone that speaks of such nonsense today will be incarcerated.”

“...”

That is obviously an abuse of power, I thought to myself. But I did not have a chance to hint that it was kind of a tyrannous move.

“I gave it a lot of thought overnight.”

“Huh?”

“As to where we’re going to go for our honeymoon.”

“Well...”

“We should head south. I heard there was a gorgeous beach with beautiful sunshine in the region of Canaria.”

“I see.”

I actually loved the idea of spending some time in the warmth of the beach. My queen continued in an excited voice.

“I heard there’s a prestigious training arena by the beach. Many renowned warriors and knights supposedly spent time honing their skills there.”

“...Huh?”

“Training you there would make it a perfect honeymoon.”

“...Pardon?”

“You’ve lost both your mana heart and mana circle.”

“I did, but--“

“Then you gotta get them back.”

“Your Majesty?”

“I’m listening.”

“Why can’t you just protect me--“

“No.”

“Why not?”

“Because I can’t wait to cross blades with you in sparring matches.”

“...”

“I am overjoyed just at the thought of spending time wisely during our honeymoon. We’ll swing blades while enjoying the picturesque scenery of

the beach and the sea, and you will struggle. It’s going to be absolutely beautiful.”

“Uh... So are you suggesting an endless session of sparring matches during the honeymoon?”

“Yeah.”

“...”

“For the entire day, from sunrise to sunset. Actually, even at night.”

“...”

“Is something wrong?”

“...”

Everything was wrong. There wasn’t anything right about the itinerary. But I couldn’t dare bring it up, because of the genuine smile on her face. I could only put up futile resistances.

“Uhm... but if you go too tough on me like that...”

“?”

“I might die, my queen.”

“It’s okay, because I will protect you.”

“...Ugh.”

I smiled but was crying on the inside. But my queen continued regardless.

“Anyhow. The time is drawing near, so I will be off to make some final preparations. Lloyd Frontera... I mean, Suho Kim.”

“...I’m at your service.”

“I ordered a nice, warm drink for you to calm your nerves with. Take a sip and be at ease. Understood?”

“As you wish, Your Majesty.”

“Hmm. You’re still calling me that.”

“...Huh?”

“You were addressing me differently before.”

“Well, there are too many people around us.”

“Then when we’re alone?”

“Yeah.”

“Good,” said she, as she stroked my cheeks and signaled with her eyes to meet again in a few moments. It did not take long for Javier to bring something on a plate.

“Master Lloyd. Your Majesty has sent you a drink.”

“...Yeah.”

I could see the steam from the cup of tea that was gently placed on the table. I chuckled without even realizing it. I couldn’t hold it in. I prayed and hoped to enjoy this much warmth and happiness for the rest of my life. I genuinely wished for everyone around me to be full of this much joy. I was confident that I could make it happen.

“Don’t you think?”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about, but congratulations nonetheless.”

“...Thanks.”

Javier had an unusually big smile on his face. I nodded towards my best man and picked up the cup of tea and took a warm, honeyed sip.

“It’s so sweet,” I inadvertently smiled out of genuine joy.

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Side Story 1: Sir Javier Asrahan's Wish

"Haven't I made myself clear when I told you to bring that thing?!"

Crack!

The candlestick flew towards the elk antler trophy hung on the wall of the tavern. That wretched, hopeless punk and drunkard began throwing another tantrum as always. I was hoping to avoid it for once, but there it was.

How long do you plan to keep wasting away like that?

I breathed a heavy sigh. This was why I clearly told the punk not to drink alcohol today. I even explained how it was my wish to spend one day in peace.

To no avail.

To be fair, it was my fault for letting Lloyd Frontera step inside the tavern in the first place. I should not have trusted him when he said he was only going to get some dinner without any alcoholic beverage. It was only two hours ago when he argued like a stubborn child, saying I am only a personal bodyguard and should not prohibit him from eating.

I should have.

But I couldn't. That was my mistake.

Or perhaps accepting this order in the first place was a mistake.

I recalled when my liege Baron Frontera summoned me a few days ago. He had said he wanted me to escort his eldest son, with a worrisome look on his face. I had simply nodded and accepted since Baron Frontera was my lord and master, whom I was going to serve for the rest of my life. Because I admired and respected him as a person. However, his eldest son Lloyd Frontera was the complete opposite.

I don’t understand why he’s wasting his life away instead of trying to emulate his father.

Shot glass flew to my face this time while I was lost in thoughts. Of course, Lloyd Frontera had thrown it.

“Take a shot!”

It was extremely easy to catch the flying tankard. I could see and feel everything, including the flow of air, even with my eyes closed. The Swordmaster Syndrome, which amplified all sensations throughout my body, was bothering me twenty-four-seven already.

“Sir Javier Asrahan... Please...”

The master of the tavern looked at me desperately. His establishment was in a state of chaos with tables knocked over, chairs broken, and bottles and plates cracked. They were all Lloyd Frontera’s doing. And the punk was continuing to abuse his power by wrecking everything in sight.

I decided to finish the escorting duty for the day. I had to cross the line. I walked over to Lloyd Frontera and grabbed the drunkard who was about to break another bottle of mead by his hand.

“Master Lloyd. I think this is enough.”

“...What?”

“You’ve drunk a lot and caused enough of a scene.”

“Ha.”

“Master Lloyd.”

To be completely honest, I had the desire to smack him across the face. This drunkard was staring at me with without focus in his eyes, and faltering like someone that couldn’t even walk straight, not to mention the smell of alcohol each time he opened his lips. It was detestable and pitiful at the same time.

“Master Lloyd. You mustn’t do this. You must realize what kind of position you’re in and the responsibility,” I said, suppressing such thoughts in my head.

“Position? Responsibility?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“Ha. Give me a break,” replied Lloyd Frontera, as he stared at me through lightless eyes and tapped my chin with his finger. “Who do you think you are, huh?”

“...”

“You’re a bodyguard. Act like it.”

“Master Lloyd.”

“How dare you.”

“...”

“Dude. Don’t you think I have it rough?”

“...”

“Because I do. Why the hell did I have to be born to a countryside nobleman? Huh? I can’t go anywhere and act like one because I’m so freaking embarrassed. Don’t you think?”

“Not at all.”

“What?”

“You’re obviously taking it all for granted.”

“Ha. You little...”

Slap!

My face turned red from the slap. Of course I saw Lloyd Frontera's flying hand, but I did not dodge because it wouldn't even hurt. But perhaps my nonchalant response caused the pathetic man to flinch a little.

"...Well."

Lloyd Frontera behaved as if he hadn't expected me to get slapped in my face. But it didn't last long.

"Ugh. You're ruining the fun."

Gulp. Gulp. Gulp.

Lloyd Frontera chugged down the bottle of strong alcohol next to him. I could see that it was a brand with high alcohol content. I anxiously examined Lloyd Frontera's reaction and breathing pattern. And I waited. It finally paid off.

"...Ugh... Damn it... This is unfair. Ugh. I... *hiccup!* have so many... things... ugh... I want to do... but my house... is so impoverished. *Hiccup!* Ugh..."

Lloyd Frontera was visibly nearing his limit. His eyes completely lost focus, and he couldn't even move his body properly.

Finally.

That drunkard was severely drunk. He wasn't going to remember anything that transpired starting right now. I signaled to the master of the tavern.

You didn't see anything. Understood?

The master of the tavern, who was holding his prized, broken elk antler trophy in his arms, nodded. With the owner's approval, I began the work.

"Master Lloyd."

"...Huh?" He instinctively turned his head towards me. And I threw a punch to his stomach.

“Urgh!”

Lloyd Frontera’s body shook from the impact.

“Ugh. Agh.”

He held onto me with his arms for a short while, before drooping down to the floor, unconscious. The peaceful silence that ensued in the tavern was so refreshing.

Perhaps I should have resorted to this earlier.

Except I couldn’t bear the consequences of my actions, should this failure of a man remember the incident. That was why I waited until he nearly passed out, and that was why I only punched him in the stomach. This way, he wasn’t going to remember what I did to him tomorrow. The pain in his stomach was going to be covered up by the hangover. I picked the knocked-out man up on my shoulders and turned toward the master of the tavern as though he was a comrade-in-arms on the battlefield.

“Are you alright?”

“Whew. Not really.”

“...”

“First, my mother falls ill, and now this.”

The master of the tavern was about to burst into tears, and I could understand why. This establishment was one of very few decent businesses in the small countryside village. It was where hunters from other regions would stop by during the hunting season, and use it as a base so they could acquire some fur and hide from the eastern mountains. Lloyd Frontera had wrecked the business, and that was obviously a huge blow for the master of the tavern who was expecting to greet seasonal visitors.

“I... will speak to the baron about what happened today,” I apologetically replied.

“About the compensation...?”

“Yeah.”

“But the rumors I’ve been hearing suggest that even the baron has been struggling financially...”

“I will speak to him anyway. I don’t know if it would work, but...”

“Whew. I really appreciate your kindness, sir knight.”

“I appreciate your patience. Please accept my apologies for what happened today.”

I couldn’t dare look the master of the tavern in the eyes. I quickly scurried off with Lloyd Frontera on my shoulder. It was already past midnight, and the misty night sky welcomed me.

“Whew...”

I inadvertently breathed a heavy sigh. To be completely honest, I was lost.

I wonder what’s going to become of House Frontera.

I really had no idea. I couldn’t understand why and how the eldest son of the good baron was such a hopeless punk, and if he was going to succeed the baron. I didn’t want to accept it.

I wish Master Julian was the eldest.

Master Julian was hard-working, wise, kind, and had the potential to make an excellent lord of the estate.

But it is only a pipe dream.

I shook my head in disappointment. Master Julian couldn’t become the next baron, because he was the second son. He couldn’t inherit the estate. That was why he had gone to study abroad in the royal academia.

That leaves this drunkard as the only person who could inherit the house and the estate.

Things were absolutely hopeless. I couldn't fathom how much further this estate would decline and the downfall of this house, to which I had sworn fealty, when that day would come.

"Whew."

I breathed another heavy sigh, as I glared at the stars in the sky.

...Huh?

That was when I saw a shooting star that flashed intensely for a brief moment and disappeared. I was reminded of a sudden phrase I had heard in the past.

Wait. If I make a wish to the shooting star, it's supposed to come true.

It was a childish superstition. I knew it was only a myth. But I was driven by an unknown desire to count on that dumb saying, most likely because I did not see a way out of this tight spot. I gave myself a leeway from facing the harsh reality and glared at the sky, waiting for another shooting star.

Flash.

And it did. I quickly iterated my wish.

My wish is for the man I'm carrying...

Swoosh.

The shooting star is always too short for anyone to complete the wish. I couldn't finish my sentence either.

...to come to his senses and start behaving like a proper young lord.

The latter part of my wish was nothing more than a mumble, as the shooting star had already disappeared. I chuckled bitterly without realizing all this.

“What the hell am I thinking.”

I found myself ridiculous. I had just made a wish to the falling star, while carrying a hopeless drunkard on my shoulder at night. And I couldn’t even do it properly.

I should get back.

I picked up a little bit of speed, holding the pathetic feeling inside. Lloyd Frontera continued to mumble like the clueless punk he was.

“Ugh... I’m so sick and tired... of working every day... I hate... my tiny room...”

I couldn’t make sense of what the drunkard was saying.

“Tsk.”

I could never bring myself to have a good opinion about this man. I hurried and headed inside the mansion, before tossing Master Lloyd on the bed. I then sat down on one of the chairs in his room to spend the night. Of course, I couldn’t fall asleep because of the Swordmaster Syndrome.

“...”

The sound of the breeze against the window frames, the flapping of owl’s wings from the woods, the heartbeat, and every single sound that existed at the moment rattled my ears without giving me a moment of peace. The worst of them all was the sleep-talking noise of the drunkard, Lloyd Frontera.

“Manager...? I really need to get paid today. You can’t hold it off any longer.”

“...”

“But you clearly promised last week you were going to.”

“...”

“I’m going to get evicted if I don’t get paid today. I’m already so behind on my rent.”

“...”

“Please, manager! How is this a good thing, when I’m struggling to pay rent? I’m being serious!”

“...”

The strange murmuring by the drunkard was so clear, and it woke me up immediately. And I was just about to fall asleep, albeit lightly.

What the...

I wondered what kind of dream he was having for this hopeless punk to desperately plea with someone. But it continued even as I looked at him with curiosity.

“I’m so sorry, father and mother.”

“...”

“If only I had gone home early that day. If only I hadn’t taken that job.”

“...”

“Javier Asrahan...”

“Huh?”

“He was so cool when he took care of the Wall of Namaran. Ehehehehe.”

“...”

I couldn’t make sense of anything the drunkard said. It appeared that he was having ridiculous dreams due to the effects of alcohol. And I realized this.

Whew. There goes my chance to fall asleep, again.

It was all because of the Swordmaster Syndrome. I wondered just when I was going to overcome this, so I could get some much-needed sleep. I was getting sick and tired of getting a few minutes every now and again. I leaned on the back of the chair hopelessly and looked at the ceiling in the midst of darkness. Lloyd Frontera's strange sleep talk continued.

"I just... want an ordinary life. I hate this... I don't want this anymore... Living day to day sucks..."

"..."

"I want it easy. I want to live in the land flowing with milk and honey... Maybe I should go to the convenience store to get some honeyed water... But that's probably just sugar in reality... And it's expensive too... Screw that... I could get something to eat with that money... Ugh..."

"..."

"Honey..."

"..."

I plugged my ears with my fingers, but still couldn't stop the drunkard from murmuring. That was how I spent my night waiting for the morning to come, enduring Lloyd Frontera's meaningless murmuring throughout.

"Javier Asrahan... what a Chad."

"..."

I wondered if he was just talking crap about me. I couldn't tell anything, save for one.

That's still miles better than his usual sleep-talk.

Even the tone in which he spoke as he mumbled was more diplomatic than usual. That was enough for me. Although I had clearly failed to iterate my wish in whole to the shooting star, I decided to take this as a form of wish granted. That made me feel slightly better.

“Good night.”

I placed the blanket, which Lloyd Frontera had kicked away, over him in the hopes that he may be a slightly better person by the time the sun rose in the morning. I just wanted him to make the slightest progress towards being a decent human being come the sunshine. I knew it was a preposterous thought, but I needed the hope to go by.

And the miracle really did happen. Lloyd Frontera had become a new person.

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Side Story 2: Your Workaholic Majesty (1)

“Your Majesty. So about the two months of staying together.”

“Yeah.”

“I am actually confused as to what this is.”

“This?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd was inside Queen Alicia’s study. He nodded as he stood in front of her desk, on which was a piece of document that particularly grabbed his attention. The queen lifted her eyebrow and nonchalantly responded.

“That’s the table showing my schedule for the day.”

“I am aware of that, Your Majesty.”

“What’s the problem, then?”

“I was wondering why there was not a single blank space in the schedule.”

“Because that’s how the chamberlain drafted it.”

“That isn’t my question, Your Majesty.”

“Then?”

“I was wondering why your schedule is so tight and does not allow you to take a single break in between, Your Majesty.”

“Hmm. That’s an unexpected question,” replied Queen Alicia, casually shrugging her shoulders as if she was stating the obvious. “Because I have that much work to do. That’s nothing out of the ordinary.”

“Then...”

“I do this on a daily basis.”

“Every single day, Your Majesty?”

“Yeah.”

“For the entire day?”

“Yeah.”

“What about holidays...?”

“What is a holiday?”

“...Ugh.”

Lloyd inadvertently teared up a little from the saddening morning conversation with the queen. He was getting the feeling that the two-month training while living together was going to be a disaster.

Crap. This is really bad.

Lloyd realized what situation he’d gotten himself into, and quickly summarized it.

I must remain calm. No need to panic just yet. Alright, so I need to figure out precisely what it is I need to do. I must stop the enforced restoration of fate and the event that could trigger it. My queen’s left arm is the trigger this time. She’s going to eventually lose her arm due to the unidentifiable paralysis, and become a tyrant in the end.

Lloyd had proposed two months of living and training together to prevent that.

I need to pass down the Asrahan Core Technique to her. As long as she masters it, her left arm is going to be cured and fate would not force itself.

The estate developer had to spend time and effort to persuade the queen, and the two-month training could barely begin. He was even able to

overcome the anticipated opposition.

I proved that I was a swordmaster in front of nobles yesterday, and was acknowledged as a worthy sparring partner for the queen, who officially declared the two-month live-in training.

All that transpired yesterday, Lloyd had not had a shred of a doubt this plan was going to work until last night, thinking all he now needed to do was focus on the training. He had confidently incorporated his own ideas into the training curriculum.

Why is her schedule like this...? She's doing different things literally every ten minutes, from granting audience and taking reports to attending meetings, greeting guests, and throwing parties, only to repeat the same thing all over again. And this is supposed to be the daily schedule and not a monthly one?

The schedule was that tight. It was as if a college student was taking courses from morning to evening without taking a break, and then moving on to night classes too. Lloyd could only chuckle bitterly in disbelief.

"Your Majesty. Are you sure this is your schedule for the day...?"

"It is. I already told you."

My queen was serious. Had she been an ordinary citizen instead of a swordmaster, this was the schedule that could have caused her to die from overworking. And she was doing this daily.

This is bad. Really bad.

But that wasn't because he had to accompany her to every location, with his wrist tied to hers.

This won't do. The Asrahan Core Technique will not work if she spends every day like this.

It was just as Lloyd thought. The schedule was way too full. Even if the estate developer was going to accompany her everywhere and engrave the

mana route in the meantime, the queen had to take time to focus on feeling, accepting, and embracing it. That was the objective. However, the tight schedule was going to defeat the purpose at this rate.

No. This really won't do.

Lloyd concluded and spoke to the queen again.

"Uhm... Your Majesty?"

"Speak."

"I don't think this would work."

"Why not?"

"Your schedule is way too tight."

"Even if you were to tag along and work on engraving the route the entire time?"

"I'm afraid so, Your Majesty."

This was why Lloyd enjoyed conversing with the queen; she would immediately identify what the problem is, even before the estate developer explained in detail, with her wits and wisdom. And Queen Alicia had done just that.

"Hmm. I think I understand the basis of your argument, Lloyd Frontera."

"Your grace knows no bounds, Your Majesty."

"...Except I haven't told you of my decision yet."

"Please forgive me, Your Majesty."

"Tsk."

"..."

“But I understand what it is you’re claiming. You’re trying to point out that the live-in training to cure my left arm must be prioritized over anything else. Correct?”

“That is correct, Your Majesty.”

“But I don’t think that would do.”

“...Huh?”

Lloyd was astonished by the response, as the queen spoke with a rough smile on her face.

“Even if the condition of my arm is of importance, this schedule was put together for the betterment of all citizens of the kingdom.”

The queen tapped on the schedule on the desk with her finger as she emphasized.

“The nobles and vassals that have shown fealty to the royal court, the residents of the royal capital, and every citizen that is born and raised within my territory are affected by what I do. Don’t you think?”

“However...”

“No. I will not hear of any counterarguments from you this time. The harder I work and the more tired I get, the more prosperous my kingdom and my people will become.”

“However...”

“Tsk. That is the weight of the responsibility on my shoulders and that of the crown on my head. Yet you ask me to postpone these. Do you think I can just accept that?”

“Your Majesty, just...”

“Just what?”

“Just two months. Can you delegate some of the work to competent vassals in your court?”

“No.”

“...”

“Not a chance.”

“...”

Lloyd couldn’t believe how adamant the queen was. It was frustrating to realize this.

God. I didn’t know she was a workaholic.

And a severe one at that. The queen wasn’t doing this for her success, renown, or wealth. She was actually on a mission to engage in selfless behaviors for the greater good of the community she was a part of. She was the most diligent and hard-working type of person.

Ugh. This is really bad.

Lloyd was getting the strong, unfortunate feeling that no persuasion attempt was going to succeed at this rate. But the queen continued to demand with a stern look on her face.

“Lloyd Frontera. Continue thinking and researching.”

“Huh?”

“Find ways to pass down the Asrahan Core Technique without interruption even while I carry out my duties.”

“...”

It was like asking the marathoner to play a flute while running, or asking a bungee jumper to eat a bowl of chicken noodle soup without spilling any.

This is beyond ridiculous.

Lloyd was stuck in a rut. He knew he needed something to rectify the situation. But the desperation he felt was unnoticed by the queen.

“Let’s get moving. Follow me.”

The queen got up and left the study, dragging Lloyd by the wrist. The immensely demanding daily schedule had just begun.

***

The day went by without a chance to catch my breath, and the night finally came.

“...Huff. Huff. Huff.”

“Are you alright?”

“...Huff. Huff. Huff.”

“Definitely not.”

“P-please forgive me, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd panted like a dog. He was out of breath, and his stamina had completely depleted. He even felt nauseous.

“U-ugh.”

He plopped on the chair in the bedroom. It was a massively demanding and overwhelming day.

I had to accompany her to five meetings, as well as several audiences and greetings that I gave up on counting, not to mention two parties and several reports that came in. To top it off, an urgent meeting was summoned in the end.

All that had transpired in just one day. But a bigger surprise was still awaiting him.

“Tsk. You’re such a fragile individual. Don’t tell me you’re fatigued by this. It wasn’t even that busy.”

“...”

“And I do this daily.”

“...”

Lloyd drooped down. His entire body was melting. But the worries just kept getting greater and greater, as he glanced at the pile of documents on one side of the queen’s desk.

“Your Majesty.”

“Speak.”

“About those documents...”

“Good. You’ve done this before.”

“...Please spare me.”

“But I am not going to kill you.”

“But...”

“All you have to do is to put the seal on each of the documents.”

“Does it have to be me...?”

“That would please me.”

Lloyd thought the queen’s way of having fun was definitely evil. The estate developer desperately wished to shout it out, but the bright smile on the queen’s face caused this thought to subside.

“I will wash up and be back. Do change in the meantime.”

“...Yes, Your Majesty.”

The rope tying the two wrists together would be untied only a few times during the day, and this was one of those moments. Now was Lloyd’s chance to wash up and change into comfortable clothes. The estate developer quickly changed into clothes that the royal court had prepared for him and thought to himself.

This isn’t going to do.

Lloyd was serious. He wasn’t able to get much work done as far as passing down the technique was concerned, while simultaneously escorting the queen to the egregious schedule. Each time he tried to stretch the flow of mana onto her left arm, the busy schedule broke his concentration, as well as that of the queen, who was certainly at the heart of each event she was a part of.

This is defeating the purpose of live-in training.

Lloyd had to come up with a solution, and the only way he could think of was to somehow reduce the amount of work on the schedule. Lloyd finished changing and washed his face using the water in the golden washbasin that the maids had brought, touching every single thought and idea that came to his mind. He took those, placed them in his brain, and blended them. Numerous tactics, strategies, and schemes came together to shed light on the best possible solution. Lloyd quickly sifted out the improbable ideas and the ones that could cause the queen to slit his throat. He finally was left with the plan that could earn him a few smacks in the head, but still wouldn’t take his life.

Good. This should do.

Lloyd had only just decided, when the queen came back into the bedroom dressed in pajamas. Lloyd had never seen the queen like this. She was wearing pink, silk nightwear that kind of looked familiar.

Wait. That looks just like the one I’m wearing.

Lloyd was appalled to realize that his blue, silk nightwear was a part of the set with the one the queen was dressed in.

No. No. No. This can’t be a couple’s item.

Lloyd suspected the maids had made a serious administrative error in bringing this set of clothes. It was unfathomable to dress in matching outfits with the queen. He was afraid that he may be indicted for the contempt of the royal court. It was nerve-wracking. Lloyd had no choice but to anxiously glance at the queen.

“What’s wrong?” The queen asked.

“N-nothing, Your Majesty.”

“Is my nightwear strange?”

“N-no, Your Majesty.”

“But yours definitely is.”

“...Huh?”

“I would call it bizarre, actually. You seem puny and pathetic in those clothes. I really didn’t expect someone to look that terrible in those.”

Lloyd became speechless at the sudden, unexpected insult that came his way. He continued to move his fingers anxiously as the queen added.

“I should order the nightwear for honored guests of the royal court to be changed. I hadn’t paid much attention to it because I looked good in them. Tsk.”

Lloyd felt a little bit more at ease upon finding out the nightwear was specifically chosen for honored guests of the kingdom.

Phew. So the queen was just using one of those without giving it much thought.

In other words, it was by no means a couple's item. But Lloyd was relieved, yet a bit disappointed at the same time.

What the hell am I thinking?

He quickly shook off the strange thought and went back to the idea he had been conjuring.

Ugh. I don't see another way.

Lloyd had to reduce the amount of work the queen was doing daily, and the only way was to turn her into a lesser of a workaholic. The estate developer contained his desperate thoughts and spoke to the queen.

"Your Majesty."

"Speak."

"Your grace knows no bounds. There is something... I wanted to propose before putting seals on these documents."

"A proposal?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"What is it?"

"To be completely honest, I am actually extremely tired."

"And?"

"But it's not like I can go against your wish and fail to carry out the task."

"Okay?"

"So, it would be really nice if I could shake the fatigue off."

“Shake the fatigue off.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“A sparring match would be perfect, then.”

“N-no, Your Majesty.”

“Then?”

“I was wondering if we could place a bet for fun, Your Majesty.”

“A bet?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Then the winner of the bet would be getting some kind of a reward.”

“Precisely, Your Majesty.”

“You have my attention.”

“Your grace knows no bounds, Your Majesty.”

“What do you want for your reward for winning the bet, and what do you intend to do to shake off the fatigue?” Asked the queen with a subtle smile on her face.

Things looked positive. This was an opportunity. Lloyd promptly began explaining as though he was reeling in a prized fish from the river.

“Have you ever heard of the game of *In Other’s Shoes*, Your Majesty?”

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Side Story 3: Your Workaholic Majesty (2)

“Have you ever heard of the game of *In Other’s Shoes*, Your Majesty?”

Lloyd’s clear voice resounded off the wall of the bedroom, causing Queen Alicia to frown.

“*In Other’s Shoes?”*

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Hmm. I can’t say I have.”

“I see.”

“What does the game *In Other’s Shoes* entail, that it will remove all fatigue from you?”

“It is a type of role-playing, Your Majesty.”

“Role-playing.”

“Yes, Your Majesty. To be precise, it is switching the roles between participants of the game.”

“Then...”

“Yes, Your Majesty. It is just as you predict.”

“So you’d dare suggest switching roles with me. What a preposterous thought.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd kept his eyes closed as he replied. Had this been an ordinary relationship between the liege and the vassal, it wouldn’t be strange for Lloyd to head to the execution block immediately. It was contempt of the

royal court, and could even be seen as treachery. He wouldn’t have a chance to defend himself. However, Lloyd was confident.

Because I have the title Grace of Magentano, thought Lloyd as he recalled the title he had. *Because I saved my queen’s life once, I get absolute trust from her, and the opinion or advice I give mostly is accepted. She wouldn’t ever suspect me of insurrection or treachery. This can work.*

Lloyd thought while he could sustain a few punches to his throat, he wasn’t going to be executed for treason. That confidence paid off, as the familiar message popped up in front of him soon.

Ding-dong!

[Your desire has triggered a certain title you possess.]

[Title <Grace of Magentano> begins to influence Queen Alicia.]

“Phew... I can’t believe it.”

As soon as that message popped up, the queen put up an empty chuckle on her face. She then proceeded to criticize my audacity in an ironically gentle tone.

“Lloyd Frontera. What should I say? I’ve never seen anyone like you.”

“Y-your Majesty?”

“I mean it,” said the queen as she stared at me, with a look on her face that suggested she wanted to smack me in the head. “Switching roles with me. Who in his or her right mind would dare propose something like that? You may be the bravest man I’ve ever seen in my life.”

“Y-your grace knows no bounds.”

“It’s not a compliment.”

“P-please forgive me!”

“It’s not a threat, either.”

“Th-then?”

“You have piqued my curiosity. I accept your bet.”

“R-really, Your Majesty?”

“Do you think I would speak of anything without meaning it?”

“Of course not,” said Lloyd quickly, before the queen changed her mind. He had to take advantage of the momentum. “Then what reward would you demand for winning the bet, Your Majesty?”

“A nighttime duel against you.”

“...”

“A sparring match that is more fierce and competitive than ever.”

“...”

“We will start while it’s still dark, and battle against one another until the sunrise in the duel that feels like a real fight.”

“...”

Lloyd was absolutely determined to win this bet no matter what now. In fact, he was already shaking from his legs at the thought of the dreadful reward.

“You wish to switch roles for the reward, while I want a sparring match. What kind of bet are we going to place?”

“I have something in my mind.”

“Speak.”

“Rock-paper-scissors.”

“Hmm. Simple enough.”

“Your grace knows no bounds.”

Lloyd prostrated. Fortunately for him, the game of rock-paper-scissors was common in this universe as well.

“Just one round determines the winner.”

“I accept,” said the queen, as she rolled up the sleeve of her nightwear.

“Are you ready, Your Majesty?” Lloyd took a deep breath and asked.

“I am.”

“Then, rock, paper...”

“Scissors says...”

The two contestants of the bet shouted out simultaneously.

“Shoot!”

Whoosh!

The two extended their respective hands, focusing on that of the opponent the entire time.

Hmm. So you’re going to play... scissors, Lloyd Frontera.

Queen Alicia’s eyes glittered with spark. Being one of the greatest swordmasters in the entire continent, she used her amazing dynamic visual acuity to examine the movement of joints, muscles, and tendons within Lloyd’s hand in the blink of an eye. She was also agile enough to switch her hand in that short period.

I shall switch to rock, then.

The queen quickly clenched her fist, but saw another movement in Lloyd’s hand. He was now clearly trying to open the rest of the fingers.

As expected.

Although Lloyd was inferior to the queen in terms of might, he was still a swordmaster too. Having realized that her vassal had decent dynamic visual acuity, Queen Alicia gave it another twist.

Whish!

As soon as Queen Alicia opened her index and middle finger, Lloyd saw the movement and internally shouted.

Urgent Foresight!

Ding-dong!

[Skill Option 7: Urgent Foresight is activated.]

[Your body temperature increases by 2°F due to the effect of the relic Eye of the Summer.]

Whirr!

Lloyd’s mana heart was quickly operated thanks to the relic Eye of the Summer. Lloyd saw five seconds into the future and changed his hand according to what the future entailed, from paper to rock, and from rock to scissors.

Swoosh! Swoosh!

In the blink of an eye, Lloyd added so many fake movements of the fingers to confuse the queen. The two contestants finally played their respective hands.

“Mm...”

The queen inadvertently let out a strange noise through her beautiful lips, as Lloyd stared at her with pride in his eyes.

“You have played paper, and I’ve played scissors, Your Majesty.”

“Y-yeah.”

“So I win the bet, Your Majesty.”

“...You do.”

The queen seemed unhappy, but Lloyd couldn’t tell if it was because she lost the bet, or because she couldn’t engage him in the midnight sparring match. Lloyd nonchalantly shrugged his shoulders, while breathing a sigh of relief.

Thank goodness. Phew.

It was the first time Lloyd used this relic that allowed him to see five seconds into the future. He had always wondered about the extent of this item, but it was phenomenal.

It’s more than amazing.

Thanks to the effect of the relic, he was able to see through each hand the queen had in her mind. He had lured the queen with a decoy hand, and this tactic worked perfectly and brought him victory.

I could have used the Attack Design option, but that’s kinda obvious.

Forcing the queen to play a hand against her will was another option, but she was the mightiest swordmaster. There was a chance she could identify the strangeness in the air as she was forced to move in a certain way. That was why Lloyd had resorted to *Urgent Foresight* instead.

“Shall we begin playing *In Other’s Shoes* immediately, then?”

“Very well. Until when?” The queen asked.

“If you would, please take a look at the constellation up in the sky,” said Lloyd, pointing out the window.

“The constellation of Phenomenon?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd added. “The constellation of Phenomenon only shows itself for fifteen minutes along the horizon around midnight during this season. And since that is up...”

“You wish to play *In Other’s Shoes* for fifteen minutes until it disappears.”

“That is correct, Your Majesty. It begins now.”

“Huh?”

Lloyd’s attitude and behavior completely flipped 180 degrees, before Queen Alicia could process her defeat.

“Alicia Termina Magentano.”

“...What?”

“What? Do you not understand what is going on?”

“...”

“What are we doing? We are playing the sacred game of *In Other’s Shoes*.”

“...”

“How come you aren’t paying me proper respect that you’re required to by law?”

“...Uh, well...”

“Well?”

“Please... forgive me.”

Queen Alicia’s face turned red. She had never even imagined in her wildest dreams she would do something like this. In fact, even when Lloyd had made this proposal, she thought it was a mischievous joke.

Ugh.

But there she was, prostrating before Lloyd Frontera to pay him respect.

Thank goodness I ordered the royal guards to stay as far away from the bedroom as possible.

The queen had given this command because she thought two swordmasters wouldn’t need any bodyguards, and for privacy reasons as well. She was glad to have done so because things could have gotten out of control had the royal guards overheard this conversation. Lloyd’s demonstration of the merciless manner of speech continued.

“Ahem. Forgive you for what?”

“Well...”

“I’m listening.”

“I am not sure,” said the queen. She genuinely knew not why she was replying to Lloyd like this, nor why and how it came to this. It was perplexing and puzzling to put it lightly.

But Lloyd Frontera had a hugely satisfactory smile on his face, as though he was enjoying every second of fifteen minutes.

“Tsk. Not knowing it isn’t going to suffice.”

“...”

“Alicia Termina Magentano.”

“Speak... I mean, I am at your service.”

“Do you enjoy working that much?”

“Huh?”

“I asked if you loved work that much.”

“...Right,” said Queen Alicia, containing the eagerness to slap Lloyd across the face. “I do.”

“You do. How much?”

“Very much.”

“More so than you love yourself?”

“...Huh?”

Confused by the question, Queen Alicia lifted her chin and looked Lloyd in the eyes, realizing he was actually serious.

That look.

It was strange. First, he had proposed the game of *In Other’s Shoes*, then he began displaying his audacity to act as the king talking to his subject and now was asking a peculiar question with a look of seriousness on his face.

“...”

Queen Alicia couldn’t make sense of the feeling that she was getting and answered honestly.

“Of course, I love the work more than myself--“

“That’s not good.”

“Huh?”

“Because I don’t feel the same way.”

“...”

“I like you more than the work itself.”

“...Huh?”

“Running the kingdom is obviously of huge importance, but it’s still not worthy compared to you as an individual. Oh, and please don’t get me wrong. I’m talking about your presence, position, and role within the kingdom when I say they’re far more valuable.”

“...”

“You are the queen of the kingdom, and I do understand the responsibility and duty the ruler has. However, all that is based on the premise that you retain your health.”

“Well...”

“What if you continue overworking yourself and lose your arm? What if your health declines? What if that prohibits you from continuing to work diligently?”

“...”

“Wouldn’t that make you an irresponsible ruler of the kingdom?”

“...”

“It is. Your constant refusal to listen to my request to take some off your plate so we could focus on our training, in reality, is an act of neglecting your duty to keep yourself healthy so you can rule over the kingdom wisely.”

“Uhm...”

“Speak.”

“Was this the reason you suggested *In Other’s Shoes?*”

“Of course it was,” said Lloyd nonchalantly, appalling Queen Alicia in the process. “Why else would I have suggested this? Would you have listened to me otherwise?”

“But...”

“I pleaded with you this morning, but you did not listen at all. You simply told me to find an alternative way to make it work, because your daily duties were of more importance.”

“...”

“So I had to resort to playing *In Other’s Shoes*. That was the only way to make you listen to me. You are more important than the work you must do on a daily basis. Your presence is way more crucial. Your health is far more urgent. You weren’t going to listen, however.”

“...”

“That’s why I tell you this. Please, please follow my advice and let your competent vassals in the court take care of the duties for just two months, and focus on your health for once.”

“But two months of my absence would...”

“It would give rise to certain problems, without a doubt. I am aware of that. However, it would stop at that, and that could certainly be rectified once this is all over. On the other hand, should you lose your left arm to paralysis, it’ll all be over. Your arm will cross the point of no return. Would you be happy with that?”

“...”

“Because I wouldn’t.”

“...”

“Nothing would sadden me more, as a matter of fact.”

“...”

Queen Alicia felt strange. The look in Lloyd’s eyes was earnest, and that was what made it even more perplexing.

“Hmm. I understand how you were genuinely feeling,” replied the queen, with an earnestness of her own.

“...What?”

“I think I get what you’re trying to say, Lloyd Frontera. Now, you may look out the window.”

“Huh?”

Lloyd turned around and noticed that the constellation of Phenomenon was no longer up in the sky. The queen’s satisfactory voice graced his ears immediately.

“*In Other’s Shoes* is over.”

Already?!

Lloyd couldn’t believe how short the fifteen-minute period was when he still had a lot to say to her. It made him feel anxious.

I wonder if she really understood what I meant.

Lloyd had shared his honest feelings about all this, using the game as an excuse. But there was no guarantee the receiver would have understood it the way he meant it.

Please...

He desperately hoped the queen would understand, and postpone her governmental duties to focus on the training for the next two months. He slightly glanced at the queen with anticipation, waiting for her response.

“Fine, Lloyd Frontera.”

“Huh?”

“I want you to lie down on the floor, face down.”

“Huh??”

“Place your hands on the floor, face down. Did you not hear me?”

“Huh?!”

“...”

“As you wish, Your Majesty.”

He quickly got down on the ground face-down, hearing the footsteps of approaching disaster. The queen sat on Lloyd’s back.

Plop!

“...Urgh?”

“Are you having difficulty enduring my weight?”

“N-not at all, Your Majesty.”

Of course he didn’t because Lloyd was a swordmaster himself. It wasn’t physically demanding on his body to hold the queen on his back while standing on four limbs, facing down. But the element of mischievous joy in the queen’s voice became greater and greater.

“I understand how you feel. I must say I appreciate the thought.”

“Your grace knows... no bounds.”

“Really? Then begin doing push-ups.”

“Huh?”

“I would like to suggest a bet as well.”

“A bet...?”

“It was you who said you care more about me than my duties and responsibilities. So I wanted to verify the integrity of your words.”

“...”

“I want to see if you can do push-ups to prove that you can withstand the weight of someone you care about.”

“H-how many?”

“Until the sunrise.”

“...Huh?”

“Continuously, until the morning.”

“...”

“Do you object?”

“W-well...”

“Speak.”

“If I succeed in doing push-ups non-stop until sunrise with you on my back, is there going to be a reward, Your Majesty?”

“Of course there is.”

“What would that be?”

“I would consider listening to and following your advice with an open heart for the next two months.”

“During the live-in training?”

“Yeah.”

“...”

“But you still haven’t begun.”

“...One million and one! One million and two!”

“Tsk. Start from the beginning.”

“...One! Two!”

Lloyd began doing wholehearted push-ups, which he didn’t even know when it was going to end. Shreds of doubt also filled up his head in the meantime.

Wait. I think verifying my integrity is all an excuse.

Lloyd was convinced that the queen was simply paying back for the insolence he had displayed during the game *In Other’s Shoes.* But it wasn’t like he could object.

Ugh...!

Lloyd’s eyes turned red as he continued pushing his body up and down throughout the night until the sun rose. He felt soreness all over his chest, shoulders, and arms while enduring the weight on his back. The estate developer, of course, internally grumbled the entire time.

Ugh. Huff. I don’t know... who it’s going to be... but whoever marries her in the future... Well, buddy... good luck, because you’re going to need it.

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Side Story 4: Eight Years Later (1)

Poor Master Lloyd, thought the silver-haired knight Javier, satisfactorily chuckling to himself. *He's going to be the weakest link in the family at this rate.*

He wasn't wrong. The scoundrel of a lord he served, whose body had been taken over by Suho Kim from another dimension, was once a swordmaster. That was Duke Lloyd Frontera, prince consort of the kingdom. He had even once led the attack on the underworld, eventually losing his physical body in the final battle against the king of hell before returning to the original body of Suho Kim in Seoul, Republic of Korea. He lost the mana heart and circle he had worked so hard to obtain, in the process.

I thought he was going to get them back easily, but...

Javier had expected his master to pick them back up without a problem, but he was wrong.

I had no idea how stagnant his progress would be.

In fact, those who had once made immense accomplishments found it easy to climb back to the top after years of hiatus relatively easily. However, the Lloyd who had returned in Suho Kim's body was different.

It's as if he had stolen everyone else's incompetence and kept it for himself.

Regardless of how rigorous he trained under the instruction of Queen Alicia, Lloyd had failed to make any significant progress. It's been eight years since his return, but he was still a low-grade sword expert.

I remember he said he'd saved some RP for the moment when he would suffer from the Swordmaster Syndrome.

Javier wondered what RP even stood for. Lloyd was still the same mysterious guy as he always had been.

“Unco Javia!”

A bubbly voice full of sincere delight graced his ears and woke him up from reminiscing. Javier lifted his head extremely slightly to greet the small girl who had already approached him.

“Unco Javia! I just did whoosh-whoosh! Did you see?”

“I certainly did. That was amazing, Your Royal Highness,” replied Javier, as he carefully and gently stroked the child’s hair with his rough hand, causing her to put a huge, satisfactory smile on her face.

“Ehehe! He said amazing!”

The child ran back the way she came like a golden retriever on the loose and began playing with the wooden training sword by the arena with the clear excitement still lingering on her face. Her movement was impressive, to say the least. In fact, it was astounding for a six-year-old girl, who was just about to turn seven in a few days of time. She was already on the verge of making the breakthrough into a low-tier sword expert.

Such an amazing talent.

Charlotte Frontera Magentano, the royal princess, most definitely took after her mother. She was already showing immense talent in sword-fighting. Javier, the swordsmanship instructor of the princess, suspected she would surpass her own father in three years at this rate.

Thank goodness she didn’t take after Master Lloyd.

She did exhibit certain sides from time to time that made Javier wonder if she had gotten it from her father Lloyd, though. Right now was such a moment.

“But unco.”

“I’m listening, Your Highness.”

“You promised. You have to keep your promise.”

Charlotte had finished her sword-play and asked Javier again. The grandmaster confusedly asked.

“Promise? I’m not sure I follow.”

“You said you were going to give me a present if I did whoosh-whoosh.”

“...Please don’t tell me...”

“You did.”

“No, no. I’m not denying the fact I made the promise.”

“Then?”

“I just couldn’t believe that you still remember the promise, Your Highness.”

“I did!” Charlotte robustly nodded her small head. “You showed me this when I was three. You said if I do this whoosh-whoosh, you were going to give me a present.”

“...”

“And I just did whoosh-whoosh.”

“...”

“But you tried to get away with just *amazing*.”

“...”

Javier wondered if the royal princess had asked for the compliment in order to see if he still remembered the promise he had made a long time ago.

“...”

It sent minor chills down his spine. Every time she showed this side of herself, Javier saw Lloyd in her. In fact, she did not care one bit about the

things that did not concern her but was extremely meticulous and persistent when it was related to her gain. She did not wish to compromise one bit, down to every penny. She was the little Lloyd back when Javier tagged along to the adventures he had gone on.

Whew.

Princess Charlotte had gotten the incredible physical talent from her highly prolific swordmaster mother, and the wits from the world's cheapest father. Javier wondered just how deadly she was going to grow into, yet suppressed the feeling with a smile on the surface. He then crouched down to make eye contact with the princess and beamed the way he would never in front of anyone else.

"Please forgive me, Your Royal Highness. I really did not expect you to still remember the promise."

"It's okay, Unco Javia. It's not your fault."

"What do you mean?"

"Papa said nobody remembers the promise to give something without a written contract."

"..."

"So the person that is receiving something has to remember it."

"..."

"He said I have to think about everything I need to receive before the bedtime story every night."

"H-he did?"

"Yeah!"

"...Alright. I will give you a present as I promised."

“Really?!”

“Of course. What kind of present do you want, Your Royal Highness?”

Javier responded with a genuine smile, expecting some kind of a cute answer from the smart and talented trainee. He was ready to give candy, a new dress or shoes, or even a new training sword.

Anything.

Javier was determined to get her anything in his power.

“Special summon.”

“Huh?”

“I want a summoned creature,” said Charlotte, in a clear and eloquent manner. “Unco Ppodo is chubby, cushiony, and soft. Aunt Bangul is gentle and kind. Unco Hama is funny. Unco Bibo is fat and I like playing on his belly. Unco Ggomi is fun to ride on. But they only listen to Papa.”

“So you want your own special summon?”

“Yeah! I want a creature of my own!”

“Your Royal Highness.”

“Yeah.”

“Please forgive me. That isn’t something I can do.”

“Why not?”

“Because I don’t know how and where to get a special summon,” replied Javier, with a genuinely sorry smile on his face. He cautiously added so as to avoid disappointing the child. “Sir Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, and Ggoming were all summoned by the duke, with the exception of Sir Bibeong who was most likely summoned by somebody else in the past. Unfortunately, I don’t know how to summon creatures like that.”

“...Aww...”

“Please forgive me. Hmm. What if we were to try this instead?”

“Huh?”

Light returned to the eyes of the child that was about to be disappointed. Javier responded with a smile on his face.

“It will be your seventh birthday, three days later.”

“And?”

“Why don’t you ask the duke for it for your birthday present?”

“Papa? For a summoned creature?”

“Yeah. I’m sure he’ll be happy too, and he definitely knows how.”

Javier was pretty positive Lloyd would go so far as to summon a special creature for his daughter as her birthday gift, although he may draft an agreement with his daughter who was going to turn seven in a few days.

Master Lloyd would never give anything away for free, especially a summoned creature, even if it was for his daughter’s birthday.

Javier suspected Lloyd would demand something like a 20% cut in allowance, or a kiss on his cheeks on a daily basis.

He definitely would.

But the little kid standing in front of him was no pushover in negotiations like this. She was the daughter of one-and-only, world’s cheapest Lloyd. Javier had expected amazing business dealing skills to be put on display, and he was spot on.

“Papa!”

An hour passed, and Lloyd visited the training arena just when the session was about to be over. Princess Charlotte giggled and ran straight to her father’s arms.

“I did whoosh-whoosh today!”

“Haha. Really?”

“Yeah! But Unco Javia didn’t give me a present!”

“Hahaha. Really?”

“Yeah! But Unco Javia said you’re going to give me a present instead!”

“Ahahaha... Really.”

Glare! Lloyd immediately gave Javier a dirty look, but the grandmaster only nonchalantly shrugged his shoulders as he watched the tension rise between the father and the daughter.

“Papa. It’s gonna be my birthday soon.”

“Yeah, it is.”

“Birthday present.”

“What kind?”

“Special summon.”

“But that’s going to be really expensive.”

“How much?”

“More expensive than him,” replied Lloyd, pointing his finger at Javier. The grandmaster was clearly annoyed, but Lloyd continued casually. “Just kidding. But those things cost a lot. Is that going to be alright?”

“It’s okay. How much?”

“Hmm. Six hundred kisses on Daddy’s cheek?”

“Can I pay in installments?”

“No. Only a one-time payment would suffice.”

“That’s gonna be bad. My lips are gonna pop.”

“Uh-oh. That’s not good. Then do you want an installment?”

“Yeah!”

“As long as possible?”

“Yeah!”

“Then I will make it a six-hundred-day installment. You give me one kiss on Daddy’s cheek per day.”

“Okay!”

“But you know installments come with interests, right?”

“How much?”

“Hmm. I will be lenient on you. 10 percent interest, so that will be 60 extra kisses.”

“...That’s too much.”

“You don’t have to take the offer if you don’t like it.”

“Uh, I don’t…*don’t like* it.”

“Then?”

“Your beard hurts if you don’t shave, papa.”

“So you want Daddy to shave every single day?”

“Yeah.”

“Haha. Okay, then it is decided.”

“Decided!”

“Okay, what do we need to do once something is decided?”

“Contract!”

“Good. That’s my daughter.”

Javier chuckled at the sight of father and daughter nonchalantly drafting and signing a contract in the spot, as he approached the duke.

“Master Lloyd. Are you sure about this?”

“Well, I guess it’ll be alright if she likes the creature that I summon.”

“I’m sure. If you would allow, I would like to wrap up today’s lesson.”

“Right. I will see you later.”

“Be safe.”

Lloyd left the training arena as Javier and Charlotte waved, and clenched his fist in excitement.

...*Nice.*

He had just won 660 kisses on his cheek from his daughter. That was two years’ worth of supply.

And it was getting tougher to get kisses from her as of late. Thank goodness.

Lloyd lightheartedly headed back, with one of his biggest concerns taken care of, with the intent to draw out the summon while he was at it since there was time.

And since even I don’t know what kind of special creature would be summoned. Should I do the premium draw, with cute-looking as one of the requirements? I should, since I have more than enough RP anyway.

Lloyd still had RP with him even after returning to Seoul after the battle against the king of hell eight years ago. Because he couldn’t really expend them, he had accumulated 27,595 RP by now.

I saved this up so I could instantly make the breakthrough to swordmaster after reaching the high-tier sword expert level. But I don’t think I could make it that far at this rate.

He had saved this up just in case, but there was no reason for him to pick up his shovel or sword in battles anymore. The lack of strife and life-threatening events prevented him from making progress, but it didn’t really matter.

My wife keeps me safe anyway.

The queen was the strongest swordmaster in the entire continent, second only to Javier. Since there was no particular reason to be stingy here, Lloyd decided to expend the RP and summon an awesome creature to satiate his daughter’s desire. He went into the cozy living chamber reserved for himself and the queen alone and took a deep breath before summoning the system window.

[Premium Random Draw]

[Drastically increase the likelihood of drawing the special creature the summoner wishes to summon, by spending a little more RP than usual.]

[Conditional Random Draw (2) = 1,200 RP]

[Current RP: 27,595]

[Would you like to perform a Conditional Random Draw?]

[YES / NO]

Yes, obviously.

Lloyd quickly selected *YES,* only to be met with an unexpected surprise.

Ding-dong!

[Your Random Draw attempt failed.]

What?

It was absolutely astonishing.

[A special summon is meant to be accompanied by you, and you alone. However, you have just attempted to summon a creature with the intent to transfer the ownership to someone else, defeating the fundamental purpose of this random draw. Therefore, your attempt has failed.]

What.

Lloyd was flabbergasted as he asked the system.

Ugh, but I'm trying to summon a creature to keep my daughter company. I can't even do that?

[No.]

The system replied adamantly.

Ugh.

Lloyd had no choice here. He couldn't override what the system had decided not to allow. No wit or clever tactic would suffice here, and Lloyd knew this from experience.

I must accept it. What a bummer.

It seemed that he had rejoiced about the deal to get a good amount of kisses from his daughter for nothing. He had to terminate the contract.

Tsk. I don't know how I'm going to explain this to her without hurting her feelings. And I wonder what she's going to demand as compensation for the breach.

Lloyd picked up some speed, as he thought the sooner he informed the other party, the less his daughter was going to be disappointed. To his relief, Javier and his daughter were still at the training arena, trying to wrap up today's session. Lloyd put on an honest, apologetic face and approached Charlotte.

"Uhm. My daughter?"

"Yes, Papa!"

"I am so sorry to tell you this, but about the contract."

"Huh?"

"I don't think it will be possible."

"What?"

"The special summon said it can't come by your birthday."

"Whaaaaat?"

"It can only come way later."

"..."

The young girl clearly became sulky, and Lloyd was flustered.

"So... I'm afraid I'm going to have to get you something else for your birthday. But Daddy will get you something way cuter and nicer."

"..."

The girl's eyes became teary. This was a state of emergency for Lloyd.

“Uh, Charlotte? Well, daddy will...”

Lloyd had to try his best to calm his daughter down for the entire evening. He was clearly having a tough time and had to endure the uneasy feeling. And he was still unable to.

Ugh. I guess I’ll have to try again tomorrow.

Lloyd strengthened his resolve to successfully calm his daughter down the next morning before he went to bed next to his wife. He was willing to take her on a picnic to the outskirts of the royal capital in a nice carriage.

He had no idea that his six-year-old girl was starting to make use of the innate ability she was born with, even without realizing, that very moment.

Ding-dong!

[Random Draw]

[You may summon a special creature by spending RP.]

[The special summon will offer the summoner unconditional loyalty alongside various special abilities and services.]

[1 Draw = 50 RP]

Charlotte Frontera Magentano, the little royal princess who had woken up from her sleep to use the toilet, began seeing the system message windows in front of her as though it was fated.

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Side Story 5: Eight Years Later (2)

“Huh...?”

The six-year-old royal princess Charlotte Frontera Magentano confusedly stared into the air, still half-asleep. At the receiving end of her gaze was the system message window.

“Random... Creature... Summon...?”

She had never seen this before. But ever since she was just a baby, she would see strange texts and hear unexpected voices telling her she had won someone’s favor and some RP as rewards. The royal princess hadn’t paid much attention to this, because the world was full of other interesting things to engage in, and because others were probably going through the same thing. In her mind, this was completely normal.

“...Creature?”

But it felt different this time. Charlotte quickly woke up from the slumber and examined the message again, as though she had forgotten about using the toilet.

[Would you like to perform a Conditional Random Draw?]

[YES / NO]

The child selected *yes* without even realizing it. She couldn’t care less about anything else such as how much RP she had accumulated thus far, and how much it cost to perform the random draw. Nothing else mattered to her at the moment save the result that followed.

Ding-dong!

[Performing Random Special Creature Draw.]

The royal princess spent 500 RP. A small something transpired five steps in front of the little girl, on the floor of the bedroom.

Flash...

Pale light graced the luxurious rug, and it soon formed complex shapes to turn into a magical seal emanating mysterious glitters.

Wh-whoa...

Charlotte’s small jaw dropped from the phenomenon. She knew not what was going on, but her little heart was beating fast with excitement.

Bzzt! The magical seal sparked, and something ascended from the floor. It flew towards the princess straight into her arms.

“Roo-roo!”

“...Whoa!”

Small, round butt, relatively large hind legs, smaller forelegs and paws, chubby tail, huge pupils, and round face, not to mention an adorable pouch by the belly. It was clear.

“A baby kangaroo?”

“Roo-roo!”

“Really? That’s what you are?”

“Roo-roo! Roo-roo!”

“You’re happy to be summoned for the first time?”

“Roo-roo!”

“I’m so glad to meet you as well!”

The small, cute baby kangaroo looked up at the princess from her arms. Charlotte quickly fell in love with the special creature and was overjoyed at the feeling of accomplishment. She had successfully summoned a creature of her own just like Papa had. This was her first special creature friend.

“Hehehehe. Hahahaha.”

Charlotte jumped for joy in the spot with the baby kangaroo Roong still in her arms, who responded with a smile of its own. The royal princess glanced at Roong again and asked.

“Uhm.”

“Roo-roo?”

“What about your mommy?”

“Roo-roo!”

“You don’t have a mommy?”

“Roo-roo!”

“Don’t you miss her?”

“Roo-roo!”

“I’m your mommy and family now?”

“Roo!”

Roong nodded robustly, before taking something out of the pouch.

“Roo-roo!”

“...Huh?”

Roong was holding a small piece of paper folded multiple times.

“Is this for me?” The royal princess asked.

“Roo-roo!”

“You want me to open it?”

“Roo!”

“...Okay.”

Charlotte took the paper and unfolded it. Fortunately for her, early education in the royal capital had made her literate at a young age.

“Hmm. So this is the instruction on how to utilize you, Roong?”

“Roo-roo!” Replied Roong with glitters in its eyes. Charlotte quickly read the instructions.

[Roong Instruction Manual]

[Roong is an adorable kangaroo that needs your love and care.]

[Roong will remain absolutely loyal to the summoner. A special creature summoned this way is a life companion and family; please do NOT ever abandon the summon.]

[Roong can change its size by consuming the two types of sunflower seeds that are complimentary to the manual.]

[Red Sunflower Seed: It will turn Roong into a giant state. Giant form duration: 12 hours]

[Blue Sunflower Seed: It will shrink Roong back to its original size if consumed before the 12-hour duration expires. Roong will return to normal without consuming the seed after 12 hours pass, but will enter a state of fatigue and growth will be unavailable for the next 24 hours.]

[It costs 1 RP to purchase a set of 2-color Sunflower Seeds.]

[Roong offers a variety of skills while in giant mode.]

[Roong’s Skills]

[Big Jump (Lv. 1)]

[Power Hug (Lv. 1)]

[Drop Kick (Lv. 1)]

[Recovery Pouch (Lv. 1)]

Whoa...

Charlotte was genuinely astounded. She still didn’t understand what skills meant, but it certainly looked so cool.

What about this?

The child opened the small pack that came with the manual, in which were ten red and ten blue sunflower seeds. The color and shapes of the seeds were so fascinating, that she inadvertently grabbed some.

“Nom. Ugh. Ptoo.”

But it did not taste great. Charlotte wiped her lips and stared at Roong.

“Roong.”

“Roo-roo?”

“Do you really become big if you eat this?”

“Roo-roo!”

“Really? How big?”

“Roo-roo!”

“That big?!”

“Roo!”

Roong proudly stretched out its small arms.

“Whoa.”

Charlotte wondered just how big was *that big.*

As big as Unco Ppodo?

Full of curiosity and anticipation, the little princess picked up a red sunflower seed.

“Roong. Can you eat it?”

“Roo-roo!”

“You want me to step back?”

“Roo-roo!”

“How many steps?”

“Roo-roo!”

“All the way there?”

“Roo!”

Charlotte quickly scurried off to the spot Roong pointed at, after handing over the sunflower seed to the small beast. She then watched ecstatically from the side, as the kangaroo consumed the red seed.

“Roo!” *Nom.*

And... the result was phenomenal. Roong now stood nearly fourty feet tall.

Wh-whoa!

The floor crumbled from the weight of the enlarged creature, and the bedroom broke apart upon contact with the expanded butt. The head and shoulders of the summon also broke through the ceiling, and the furniture and fixtures in the process.

Crumble! Rumble! Crush!

The prestigious table passed down to all royal princesses of the kingdom shattered, not to mention the rocking chair, a cushiony sofa that served as the trampoline, the containers holding drawing and painting tools, silver candlesticks, and chandeliers. The bedroom of the royal princess had turned into an absolute shipwreck, but Charlotte hadn't sustained any injuries thanks to Roong's timely intervention with her enlarged hands.

"Whoa! Amazing!"

Charlotte's eyes sparkled with excitement. She was now holding a blue sunflower seed in her hand.

"This, too, then!"

"Roo-roo!"

The fourty-foot tall, muscular kangaroo opened its mouth, and Charlotte threw the seed into it.

"Roo-roo!" *Nom.*

And the result was instant.

Poof!

Roong was a small, baby kangaroo again, as if it hadn't turned into a giant. Charlotte became ecstatic. She couldn't care less about the wrecked furniture in her bedroom.

"Let's do it again!"

She took out the red seed again.

“Roo!” *Nom.*

Crush!

The kangaroo instantly grew to fourty feet again, breaking other heritage items within the bedroom. Guards on duty outside of the royal princess’s chamber were flabbergasted by the mysterious event. They had been, ever since the first growth.

“Y-your Highness! Are you alright?!”

“Your Highness!”

“Urgh! The door won’t budge!”

“Push harder!”

The broken bed and other fixtures had blocked the entrance to the chamber, causing the guards to panic outside.

“Break it!”

Thwoosh! Crush!

Each of the elite guards on duty was at least an intermediate sword expert. The door broke down along with the fixture blocking the path thanks to their endeavor, turning Charlotte pale in the process.

“...I think I’m in trouble.”

The little child finally saw the catastrophic aftermath of what she had done.

“Roong. What should I do? I’m gonna be in trouble.”

“Roo-roo?”

“C-can you take me and run away?”

“Roo-roo!”

Roong nodded robustly in response. In fact, the enlarged beast thought it was a walk in the park.

“Roo-roo!”

The kangaroo stretched out its enlarged hand and picked up the child cautiously, before placing the princess in its cushiony, comfortable pouch. Charlotte felt warmth and coziness from within, as she saw the system message window pop up again.

Ding-dong.

[You have entered Roong’s pouch in giant mode.]

[Conditions for Roong’s skill Recovery Pouch have been met.]

[Skill will activate immediately.]

[Recovery Pouch]

[You will recover from fatigue and most injuries with 20 times more efficiency while you stay within the pouch of Roong. It also offers unusual comfort of sleep, even to those that suffer from Swordmaster Syndrome.]

Stomp! Roong stomped on the floor while Charlotte was busy reading the message. The forty-foot, colossal, and muscular kangaroo then jumped forward and crushed the wall, leaping across in the air from a five-story height. The royal guards on duty by the royal garden saw something they could bring up again and again while having a drink with their friends.

Thump!

The landing was massive and shocking. But the beast stomped on the ground again, before it stopped shaking.

Stomp!

“Wh-what the hell is that?”

“Her Royal Highness has been abducted!”

“What?! Stop the beast!”

“S-stop what? Urgh!”

The gorgeous, well-maintained royal garden was no more, as the fourty-foot tall kangaroo wreaked absolute havoc, uprooting trees and boulders from the ground and leaving royal soldiers panicking in its wake. The huge commotion reached the ears of Lloyd and Queen Alicia, who had been enjoying their beauty sleep on the bed next to each other, and woke them up.

“What’s going on?” Asked Queen Alicia, looking out through the window.

“Uhm... That looks like a special summon,” replied Lloyd, who was just as confused.

“Special summon? Like Sir Ppodong and Sir Bangul?”

“Yeah.”

“How do you know?”

“Because that gigantic kangaroo just shouted out *Roo-roo*. And I can understand it.”

“What did it say?”

“Well...”

“Speak.”

“It said... I love playing with my new master! I love my master Charlotte!”

“...”

“So, basically...”

“That kangaroo was summoned by our child,” the queen intervened.

“Looks like it.”

“Are you hearing things?”

“No.”

“Did you drink without my knowledge?”

“No.”

“...Well, but our child isn’t in danger.”

“Except the royal guards probably are.”

“...”

Lloyd and Alicia breathed a deep sigh at the same time as they looked out at the garden full of uprooted trees and boulders, through which the colossal kangaroo was frolicking joyfully. They then saw the face of their daughter inside the pouch of the creature, as well as those of royal guards who clearly seemed flabbergasted. Something had to be done. The wife and husband quickly made eye contact and changed into everyday clothes.

“Hang onto me, since time is of the essence.”

“Okay,” Lloyd followed immediately, as Queen Alicia carried Lloyd like the knight in shining armor carrying the princess and jumped out the window.

Step. Dash!

Having landed softly like a cat, Alicia did not hesitate to dash towards the gigantic kangaroo. Lloyd shouted out while hanging tightly onto her arms.

“Hey! Kangaroo! Stop it!”

“Roo-roo...?”

Roong paused for the first time at the voice of a human that sounded rather familiar and friendly. It was the first time it heard a voice like this aside from its master Charlotte.

“Papa...?”

“Yeah. Papa and mama.”

“Ugh,” said Charlotte, before completely placing her head inside the pouch.

“Daughter! Time to stop playing! You must go to sleep!” Lloyd shouted out more desperately.

“...”

“I won’t get mad! I promise!”

“...Promise?” Charlotte took a peek out again and looked down on the ground. Mama and Papa were staring at her, but not with the intent to scold her.

“Of course! I promise!” Lloyd shouted again.

“Really?”

“Really!”

“But you’re gonna say that wasn’t what you meant.”

“I promise as well,” said Queen Alicia.

“Really?” Charlotte’s response was finally bright. She looked at Roong and spoke.

“Roong!”

“Roo-roo?”

“These are my parents!”

“Roo-roo!”

“Time to eat this!”

Charlotte took out the blue sunflower seed and fed it to Roong, who became small in an instant. Lloyd quickly reacted and captured the falling child with his arms.

“There. I got you.”

“Tee-hee.”

“Tee-hee? This isn’t funny, my princess.”

“...But you promised you won’t get mad.”

“Well, I certainly did,” replied Lloyd, before turning his gaze to his wife. “Tsk.”

Alicia shook her head, and there was nothing else Lloyd could do except ask Charlotte what he wanted to know.

“Are you alright? Did you get injured?”

“No. I’m fine.”

“Did you get hurt?”

“No.”

“Okay, then how did you summon Roong?”

“Random draw!”

“...What?!”

Lloyd was astonished by his daughter’s response. He had thought he was the only one that was able to perform such a task.

“You did... a random draw?”

“Yeah!”

“Did you by any chance... see strange texts in the air?”

“I did!”

The response that followed confirmed Lloyd’s suspicions.

“I have RP too!”

“You have RP...?”

“Yeah! I had RP since I was a baby!”

“How much?”

“53!”

“Haha. Hahaha.”

Lloyd burst out laughing. It was surprising and cute. But he was yet to be done.

“And some circles after 53.”

“Circles?! Zero, you mean?”

“Yeah!”

“How many?”

Lloyd was flabbergasted. He finally realized that the child had seen the system message ever since her birth, and saved RP as she grew.

But she didn't show any signs, not because she deliberately tried to hide it, but because she thought seeing the system message and collecting RP was a natural thing that everyone probably did. It was so natural, just like water and air in the atmosphere. She probably didn't find this strange at all.

Perhaps she grew up thinking that everyone around her was constantly being harassed by such messages, Lloyd thought.

But zeros after 53...? The estate developer wondered just how much RP his daughter had. *Maybe 530... or even 5,300.*

Even that was an immense amount, as he had about 7,000 RP when he was battling the king of hell, and had gathered a little more than 20,000 RP in the past eight years.

Adorable.

Lloyd was delighted to know that the child he dearly cherished had inherited this strange skill and ability. It was cute that his only daughter had gathered what little RP she could like treasure. But yet another shocking information awaited him, as Charlotte folded and unfolded her small fingers.

"Uhm... One. Two. Three. Four. Four circles!"

"...Four?!"

"Yeah!"

"Hold on a sec. So you have... 530,000 RP?!"

"Yeah!"

"..."

Lloyd felt like he was struck by an extraterrestrial being from the galaxy. It was as if he was bragging about winning five dollars in front of someone who had won the jackpot.

“W-well, I see. Listen.”

“Yeah.”

“Daddy will teach you how to best use RP. Okay?”

“Okay!”

“Shall we go back and get some sleep?”

“But I don’t have a bed. My bedroom broke.”

“It’s okay,” replied Lloyd with a satisfactory smile, as he picked up his daughter and gently tapped his wife on her shoulders. “You can come and sleep with mommy and daddy.”

It was time for the three of them to share the bed, and it was going to stay that way for some time. Lloyd turned around, looked at everyone, and spoke with a huge smile on his face.

“Right?”

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Side Story 6: Epilogue

Flap!

The king of hell flapped his wings fiercely as he flew around in the space.

Whoosh.

It was vast and mostly empty. The king lifted his chin and examined the movement patterns of every moving thing in the vicinity, before descending.

Whoosh!

Six legs were folded as the wings zapped. The former ruler of the underworld viciously and ruthlessly landed near his target.

Thud!

The king of hell satisfactorily licked his lips as he looked pompously around like the force of nature he was.

Feeble things around him grabbed his attention. The king of hell violently swept through the small crumb of chips... or so he thought. A fly swatter flew his way.

Wham!

The swatter slammed against the desk, and the king of hell barely managed to escape doom and flew away in time. He flapped his wings even more viciously to continue traveling, as colossal humans conversed with one another.

“Oh, no. It got away. You’re terrible, girl.”

“Ugh, it’s not like I can use the spray in the hospital.”

“Just give me the swatter.”

“Oh, yeah? Let’s see how you do it then.”

“Watch and learn, haha.”

The two nurses by the neatly maintained desk lightly bantered, and the king of hell instinctively knew it was dangerous here. He needed to get away. The fly’s flapping of wings became even more diligent as he quickly traveled across the hallway of the hospital as the voice of the news reporter spoke through an old-school television in one of the rooms.

“Bringing news from Lillehammer Winter Olympics. I’m sure everyone still remembers the outstretched leg of the skater who won the Republic of Korea the first gold medal in the Winter Olympics history. The same skater, Kihun Kim, has delivered another scintillating run to win gold in men’s short-track skating for 1,000 meters. Connecting to a live reporter at the scene.”

Buzz.

The sound from the television declined as the king of hell viciously flapped his wings and moved away from it. The fly continued traveling and headed inside the elevator, from which he barely escaped after ascending and descending a few floors. He then fiercely flew in the hallway of a different floor of the hospital, until a certain man clapped with pinpoint accuracy.

Slap! Pop!

The king of hell, who had ruled over the underworld tyrannously and mercilessly, was reborn into the body of a fly in a whole new dimension. And he just ended his new life.

“Eww. Why is there a stinking fly in the hospital?”

The man in his mid-thirties wiped his hand with the handkerchief, not realizing what accomplishment he had just made by slaying the supreme being that used to manage the underworld across the dimensions. He had no idea that the nonchalant clapping of his hands just crushed this force of

nature to death. The man continued walking down the hallway until he saw an old man sitting on the bench and greeted him.

“You really don’t have to. I don’t want you to go through the trouble.”

“No, it’s okay. How can I leave, when my grandson is struggling to survive?”

“But you should still get some rest. You haven’t rested for some time.”

“Tsk. I can’t bring myself to.”

“I’m sure it’s going to be alright. He’s a bit underweight, but the doctor said he’s breathing fine. He should be able to get out of that thing after a day or two.”

“Really?”

“Yeah.”

The man and the old father-in-law stared through the transparent glass and watched the incubator inside the room. A boy was resting in one of them. It was the villainous and impish, original Lloyd Frontera that had just been reborn into the body of the infant.

They speak with an interesting accent, not to mention how loudly he talks. Hmm. I suppose I am his son.

He was just born in the morning and couldn’t even open his eyes to see anything yet. He could still hear the conversation from outside of the room, especially because the man and the old father-in-law spoke loudly and clearly.

They sure talk a lot.

The bum Lloyd instantly realized they were his new family. He grumbled because he had wished to be reborn as a whale out in the ocean. He wondered what kind of world he was in, as he recalled what he had just experienced at the gate of rebirth.

The gate felt so strange.

He had finally gotten some peace for the first time since his death, after bidding farewell to the fake Lloyd, Suho Kim, who had stolen his original body on the platform at the end of the underworld. Real Lloyd was able to step through the portal of rebirth thanks to fake Lloyd's kindness and help.

Ha. I'm not sure if I'm supposed to be grateful or mad at him.

He chuckled out of confusion. While he resented the fact that the fake Lloyd had stolen his body and thus caused him to wander restlessly between the underworld and the human realm like an apparition, he was grateful for the help the fraudster provided after the coincidental encounter in the underworld.

Thank you, Suho.

The bum Lloyd internally expressed his gratitude and strengthened his resolve to lead a new life, remembering the kindness Suho had shown him in the underworld to help him pass through the gate of rebirth. He also regretted how he led his previous life.

Father, mother, and Julian.

It was heartbreaking to think about his family. Although there were things he particularly did not like about them, he could only think of all the mischief and trouble he had caused as the eldest son of the house. He regretted having yelled out in anger to his father. He regretted having failed to listen to his mother. He regretted having failed to treat his younger brother Julian with more love.

And Javier Asrahan.

He also recalled the dirty look his bodyguard gave him.

Right. You must have found me so despicable.

He acknowledged that it was a fair assessment of his character. Lloyd realized that he had nothing to complain about, even if the scorn was from

his own parents or brother Julian. There was no room for any excuses to come into play. He was trashy and unworthy. He was a bum. He had only caused inconveniences for others.

I am so sorry, everyone.

The bum Lloyd shed tears out of regret. He repented, but it was too late. So he decided to work hard and be benevolent in the second lease in life. He wanted to lead the life that Suho Kim had, helping others instead of causing trouble. He strengthened his resolve and reiterated this to himself. He was determined not to forget this new attitude and mindset, which were going to fade away soon due to the law of rebirth.

I clearly heard what to expect after being reborn. I would retain a part of my memory from the previous life pertaining to the intellectual ability of my new body, but even that should fade away fairly quickly.

He heard he would forget all memories from his past life, the moment he heard his name for the first time. The bum Lloyd desperately tried to engrave this mindset and attitude within himself before it was too late.

The conversation between his new father and maternal grandfather could be heard from outside the room.

“By the way. Have you thought of a name for the kid?”

“Huh?”

“So you don’t, yet,” said the old man.

“Well, I do have something in my mind,” replied the father awkwardly.

“I see. But you should still hear an old man out.”

“I’m listening.”

“I actually consulted a renowned shaman and got a really good name that would bring him good fortune.”

“From... a shaman?”

“Yeah. Looking at the kid’s birth hour, day, and year, he suggested a perfect name.”

“What is it?”

“Palbong. Palbong Kim.”

“...”

“Well? Do you like it?”

The man remained silent. The bum Lloyd was in a state of emergency.

Tell him no! What kind of name is that?!

Lloyd knew not what were trendy, cool names in this universe, but the name the old man just suggested sent chills down his spine for some reason.

No. I don’t know why, but no. That’s not the name. Come on, dad! Decline it! Who names his child Palbong?!

Lloyd genuinely began cheering for his father like a sports team. To his relief, the support seemed to have reached him.

“Well, uhm...” said the man in an uneasy tone.”

“What is it?”

“Can you please reconsider?”

“Why? Do you not like Palbong?”

“Uh, well... I really appreciate how you went out of your way to get a recommendation and all, but Palbong is just... not fit.”

“Why? Because it sounds too old-school? That’s nothing to worry about. A boy’s name should be old-school and conventional!”

“But still...”

“Hahaha, but I paid 200 dollars for this name.”

“...”

“He’s going to lead a good life, without any trouble with this name.”

The man became speechless again, causing the bum Lloyd to internally shout out more desperately.

Old man? Gramps? Are you out of your mind? Was that name blessed by priests or something? Why would you play around with somebody’s name?!

He was afraid of being given the terrifyingly horrible name the old man suggested. The bum Lloyd shivered in anxiety, but it didn’t conclude that moment.

“Very well, please give me some time to think about it.”

“Understood.”

The voices of the two men faded away. It appeared that they were going somewhere while conversing with one another. The bum Lloyd breathed a sigh of relief and felt extreme fatigue all of a sudden.

Phew. Thank goodness. For now.

It was fortuitous that he wasn’t given that name at the moment thanks to his new father’s intervention. It was clear his father did not like that name.

Come on. Be more assertive. It’s your own son!

The bum Lloyd desperately wished for his father to express his thoughts more clearly. But he gradually felt more fatigued and tired, and couldn’t overcome the urge to fall asleep.

I guess it’s because I’m a newborn...

He couldn’t resist. Lloyd fell asleep like that, and couldn’t think of anything anymore. It was comfortable and cozy. He was sound asleep.

***

He did not know how many hours had passed when he fully woke back up. He recalled how he had awakened a few times in the middle of the sleep, only to pass out again.

He tried to pay attention to his surroundings, which clearly felt a bit different. The air was different as well. The cozy warmth surrounded him as if somebody was holding him, and the voices of people were louder than ever.

“Oh, he woke up.”

It was the voice of the man from before, but in a whispering manner, followed by the voice of a woman.

“Honey. Are you sure about that name?”

“Yeah. I don’t think we can persuade your father, so we’ll just have to do it.”

“But he may be upset if he finds out about it. He even went to the shaman.”

“It’s okay. Do you want to name our kid Palbong?”

“...No.”

“See? I thought the same. I love my father-in-law, but that’s a bit of a stretch.”

The conversation was clearly between his new father and mother. The bum Lloyd breathed a sigh of relief, as it appeared that his parents were intent on declining the terrible name.

I wonder what my new name is going to be.

It was going to be decided soon, and he would forget the memories from his past life the moment he was called by the new name so he could lead a whole new life.

And I won't screw up this time. I swear.

He recalled everyone that he felt sorry for from his previous life such as his family and knights in his service, and vowed again never to forget this mindset even if all memories were lost. The huge hand approached the baby as he strengthened his resolve, and cautiously and gently touched him in the forehead.

"You're so small and adorable."

"Stop. You're going to make him cry."

"Even if he does, he'll still be so cute."

"Haha."

"Alright then, we agree on the name, right?"

The woman's body slightly rocked as she held the baby. It appeared that she was nodding to her husband's response. The bum Lloyd nervously anticipated what kind of name he'd be given. He was curious about the new life that was ahead of him. He was full of worries and excitement at the same time.

And the gentle voice of his new father graced his ears.

"Do you hear me? This is your dad. I'm so excited about raising a boy."

...Huh?

That was when the bum Lloyd began forgetting things. Memories about the Frontera Estate when he was young, the picnic he went on with his family, and when he made fun of Javier and ran away began to fade away and pop like bubbles, one by one.

“My boy.”

The moments he cherished and loved slowly but surely disappeared with each word his new father spoke.

“Suho Kim, my beautiful son.”

The gentle touch from his father’s hand on the baby’s cheeks caused the former bum Lloyd to put a smile on his face. The baby Suho Kim was genuinely delighted to start anew.

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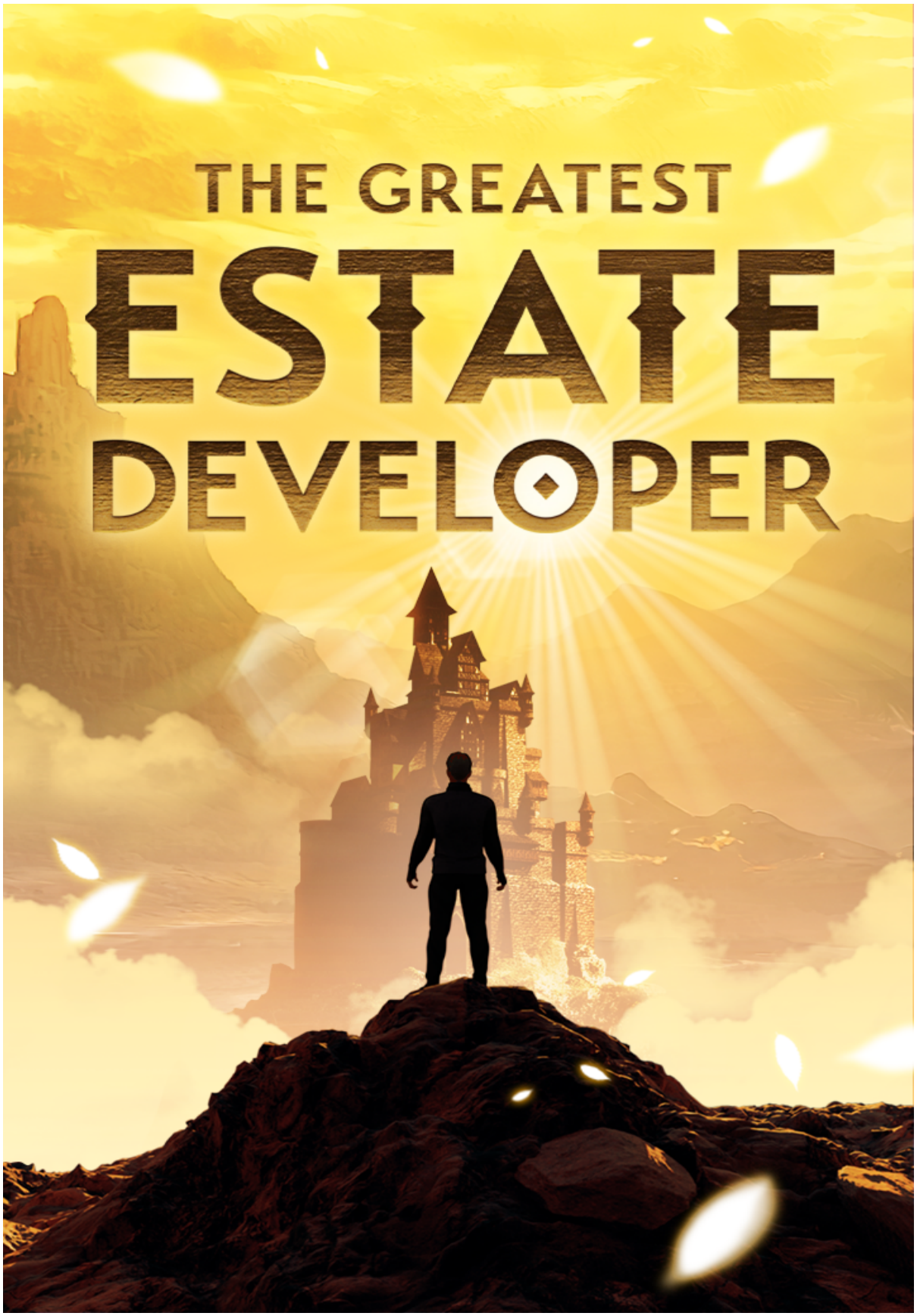
THE GREATEST
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Chapter 1: I Become a Villain in a Novel

Something that seemed like a work of fiction happened to me. When I opened my eyes, I was in *The Knight of Blood and Iron;* an epic novel about the indomitable leadership of ice-cold protagonist Javier Asrahan. I'd been sucked into the grandiose realm of the book, as the drunken young master whom Javier served in his unremarkable early years. At the time I couldn't imagine that this would be the beginning of my own epic story. How could a mere civil engineering student become the guardian of this world?

***

[RP (relationship point) system activated.

You can earn RP by improving your relationships with the main characters.

You can acquire special skills in exchange for RP.]

[Current RP: 0]

A strange message rang in his head like an alarm, and he wondered what this RP and skill development was all about. *I'm tired and sleepy*. Suho scowled as he lay back on the bed. It was annoying, but it was typical.

He attended classes during the day. He worked hard at a part-time job in the evening. Meanwhile—in an attempt to change his mood–he spent all night reading a novel. So, it was only natural that he felt tired. Actually…it was more like karma.

But I still finished all my assignments. I can sleep in for thirty more minutes. The very thought put a smile on his face. However, Suho's smile didn't last for long.

"…up, please."

He heard an unfamiliar voice. The voice was cold and direct. *Is this a dream?* Assuming he was hearing things in his sleep, Suho flopped over onto his other side. But the adjustment didn't block out that urgent voice.

“It’s late. It’s time to get up, Master Lloyd.”

Huh…? It wasn’t a dream. The voice was definitely coming from right next to him. *But how?*

He suddenly emerged from his confusion and came to his senses. This was a dorm room of just over seventy square feet, and he always kept the door locked. Yet somehow, someone was in his room talking to him?

Suho cautiously opened his eyes. His body involuntarily tightened up.

“You are awake sir. You woke up right away today, I see.”

A handsome man with silver hair sat patiently beside the bed. He didn’t look a day over twenty years old. His face revealed not one ounce of laughter in it, which nicely matched his figure—which resembled a sword of ice carved from the top of a glacier.

“Javier… Asrahan?” Suho mumbled involuntarily.

It was certain. This was the book he spent all last night reading: *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* The illustration of the epic’s hero—Javier Asrahan—looked just like him. They were identical. Even his smirk was as stylish as that painting.

“So, you finally remembered my name. Thank you, sir.”

His expression, however, didn’t look the least bit thankful.

“But what am I doing here?” Suho blurted out loud.

Javier’s smirk deepened a little more. “Master has put me in charge of escorting you.”

“His Lordship? Escort?”

“That is correct.”

“Why?”

“To prevent events such as last night from happening again.”

“But last night, I was…”

“You were so drunk you couldn’t walk. Three tables, five chairs, nineteen dishes, and six candlesticks were damaged when you threw a fit at the pub. Ah, and the pub owner’s precious ornamental buffalo horn table was also destroyed entirely.”

I’m innocent… Really. I was just reading a book in my room. But then he felt a throbbing pain in his head. *I didn’t even drink, yet I have a hangover? Well, that’s not fair.*

“Hmm. Then first, get me some water.”

He wanted to get his mind back in order. While taking sips of the water Javier fetched him, he looked around the bedroom. It was unfamiliar, yet it was large and tidy. It was on a totally different level from the grubby, tiny dorm room and its scruffy yellow walls. *This is pretty awesome.* He wondered if he really was reincarnated into a literary character. Nobility, at that! Suho accepted this “reality” in his own way. This was heaven compared to the miserable, lonely life in the dorms.

But something caught his eye.

“What’s that?” Suho pointed at the cupboard on the other side of the bed. A conspicuous red piece of paper was stuck to the cupboard. And it wasn’t the only one. They were on the large desk, the refreshment table, on the bed where Suho lay, and even the chair on which Javier sat. Every single piece of furniture had a red ticket stuck to it.

Could it be…? Absentmindedly, Suho swallowed.

Then Javier replied to Suho’s inquiry, “Have you forgotten already? They are repossession notices from yesterday.”

It was a terse response. Suddenly he recalled the fact that, at the beginning of the novel, the baron who hired Javier had fallen into ruin.

A con artist fools the baron and baroness. They lose their estate and their land and then take their own lives. And Lloyd, their eldest son? His alcoholism makes him sick, and he dies. Javier makes a grave for Lloyd and then leaves the fiefdom. That's when Javier Asrahan takes his first steps as the star of this grand epic.

So, I'm possessing the body of that brutish young master who dies from alcoholism at an early age? That's me?

His joy at becoming a nobleman quickly fizzled out. Either way, it was a big problem.

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"Ugh, it's true. It is actually true."

Some hours later, Suho…no, Lloyd looked at himself in the mirror. His full-length mirror also had a red repo tag attached to it, just like all the other furniture. A sleek, dark-haired man stood there looking back at him.

It was Lloyd.

So that's me now. He still had trouble accepting the reality of what had happened. Yet, he didn't hate it either. Honestly, he kind of liked it. His life back in South Korea was only full of hardship.

I did nothing but suffer.

Suho was the only son of an ordinary family. He'd passed the college entrance exams and become a civil engineering student. But trouble came while he was serving his mandatory duty in the army. His parents were cheated out of their lives as victims of a real estate investment scam. The only thing they left him after they died was colossal debt. Their house and all of their property were seized. To avoid taking on the remaining debt, he had to give up his inheritance.

Without the scholarship money for low-income students, I would never have been able to attend school.

He was diligent in his studies, but the cost of living was a separate matter from tuition. He bounced between several part-time jobs, but it was no easy task to keep up good grades while working. His dorm room was no more than a cramped closet. He would get seven nosebleeds a day. The free kimchi and rice served at the dorm were the last defense keeping his body alive. With only that, Suho managed to tightly cling on to life…up until yesterday.

But to think that I became a nobleman from an old book I picked up. Now I can truly breathe.

He wasn't even as grand as a duke or a count. He was a mere baron in charge of managing a countryside fiefdom. However, that made being Lloyd appeal to him even more.

I probably won't be getting into any kind of big mishaps, like a rebellion or something. That was always the problem in any historical or medieval drama. It didn't matter if you were a well-off aristocrat. Once you got tangled up in a rebellion, it was over. There was no room for excuses, and you were beheaded in one fell swoop.

I'd much rather be the baron of some remote area. It's like its own niche market. No big conspiracies, just the countryside and a sweet life of affluence. He could live a life of ease if he held on to his comfortable, stable status. *Although, that can only happen after the baron's debt is settled.*

That was the problem.

Why now of all times?

He recalled Javier's explanation. Those repo tags were placed yesterday. So, what could've happened if he'd possessed Lloyd's body a month or two sooner? He could have prevented the baron from being conned. Now he felt like he wanted to grab the author by his shirt collar.

Well, it's already happened, so now I must fix it. If he didn't, by next year the baron and baroness would commit suicide. Selling this house and

fiefdom would make him into a beggar.

Just like back in Korea.

That was a nightmare of a thought. He rejected the very idea of it and had no interest in a repeat. So somehow or other, he had to come up with enough money to cover the baron's debts.

He looked into the mirror for a long time. Then suddenly, something popped into his head. Turning to the frosty Javier beside him, he asked, "Hey."

"Yes, Master Lloyd."

"Does our estate have a lot of money?"

"Sir?"

"If I asked the people for money, how much would it be?"

"Are you referring to a tax?"

"No, not that."

"Then?"

"Something like a gold collection campaign…ugh, never mind."

Lloyd shook his head. If he gathered funds from the people, it might help. But thinking about it more, it didn't feel quite right. Obviously, without a good reason, asking the people for money would result in dissent. *I wouldn't be able to pay all of it off with that amount anyway.*

He thought about the introduction from the novel. The time limit to pay off the debt was two years. But before the time was up, the baron and baroness commit suicide. The pressure of the debt continued, and the interest kept growing. The pathway to settling the debt was a dark, murky swamp, and the couple drowning in that debt let go of their hope.

That's exactly one year from now.

And five months later, Lloyd dies vomiting blood in the pub where he was a regular. The very beginning of *The Knight of Blood and Iron* describes all of this.

Dammit. Is this some kind of déjà vu? It was basically a mirror image of what happened to his family back in Korea. Thinking about it spoiled his mood.

"Hmph. Let's take a walk or something."

Walking is the best way to clear the mind. Even back when he was still Suho Kim, walking was part of his routine. Actually, it was pretty much the only comfort he had, since it didn't cost any money.

So, he and Javier left the room and entered the hallway. Just then he encountered a woman approaching from the opposite end of the hall. The woman carried herself with sophistication and elegance. She was a beauty who'd aged gracefully into her middle years.

Could it be…?

Suddenly a name popped into his head. *Marbella Frontera.* She was the baroness. Lloyd's mother. She was the only middle-aged woman in this estate who could have that kind of air about her.

Lloyd gulped dryly. *Of course we would run into each other.*

Is there a parent who does not recognize their child? He worried that she would catch on to the fact that he was a fake. Thankfully (?!), he worried in vain. As soon as the baroness looked his way, she clicked her tongue at him.

"Did you go out drinking again?" That look she had in her eyes… It was full of heartache and worry. Was it because her son was unseemly—drinking his life away and raising hell—all while their home was being torn apart? There was no way of knowing.

"You should enjoy it in moderation. It is not good for your health."

The baroness sighed quietly and brushed past him. Lloyd was left assured. *I didn't get caught. But should I really be happy about that?* Lloyd Frontera. A guy who drank the moment he opened his eyes in the morning. Thanks to that, even his own mother had such a poor opinion of Lloyd. *That's pretty sad, though.*

Then Suho recalled his time as a freshman; back when his family was still affluent. Back then he was rather ignorant. He remembered drinking every day, be it at lunch or on a class trip. Each time, his mother would cook haejang-guk for him… Hangover soup. However, it had become a part of the past.

Humph. Lloyd bit his bottom lip. His stride lengthened as he left the house. That could be why the townsfolk he met along the way scurried off to the side of the road as soon as they noticed him. They all hung their heads to avoid making eye contact. One woman trembled while she squeezed her hands together tightly. Some of the villagers grew visibly pale. Was he coming to grips with his situation within that short span of time?

Right, this is the kind of guy Lloyd was.

The story flashed through his mind. The Beast of the Frontera Barony. That was Lloyd Frontera. He got drunk and would occasionally throw or break things. It was a given that he wrought abusive language and violence upon those below his station. Simply put, he was the worst kind of troublemaker. Human gutter trash.

That's why they're all so spiteful. I'm completely despicable. A bitter laugh escaped him.

"Hey," he whined to Javier beside him, "what's with all of them? It's not normal to treat a lord's son that way."

It was common sense that the lord's son was the most powerful man in the region. So, unless the lord's son was some kind of a dirtbag… They usually tried to smile and at least pretend to respect him. Like the store owner who kindly served the landlord's son their fried chicken. Or like a senior manager who became overly lenient to the president's son when he started

as a new employee. *Shouldn’t the son of this estate’s owner be the same to its villagers?*

“Normally, but.”

“Normally… But?”

“Yes.”

“Then what about now?”

Javier replied coldly, “It’s a state of emergency.”

“Emergency?”

"It refers to the appearance of a being who poses a threat to the livelihood, welfare, and safety of the people of the estate."

"And…that *being* is supposed to be me?"

“That is correct.”

“That was quite the comeback.”

“What is a comeback?”

“Uh…like cutting someone to the bone with facts.” Javier stared intensely in his direction. His expression showed confusion over the nonsense he’d just heard. And yet, like a painting, he was cold and stately.

Sure, that is the kind of guy Javier was. A noble, honorable knight. A man relentless against injustice. He was a hero and the epitome of knighthood. In the novel, Javier becomes renowned throughout the entire continent of Lorasia. Naturally, just because he was still unknown at this point, didn’t mean his personality was any different.

“I’m unsure what to do in this situation. I’ve not once been disloyal to you, Master Lloyd.”

“Not once?”

“Never.”

“So, you’ve never heard of a fact attack?”

“I know nothing of it.”

“Have you ever detested me then?”

“No. Never.”

But…it definitely seemed that way from his expression, Lloyd realized. *This guy hates me too.*

Being the virtuous knight that Javier was, he emphasized the importance of honor. So, it was certain he hated a churlish dirt-bag like Lloyd. And yet, he was the kind of guy who’d stay loyally by his side until the day Lloyd died. It seemed he upheld his obedience and loyalty to his master the baron until the very end. *An amazing guy, at any rate.*

And one of the best swordsmen in the history of the Lorasian continent—an unprecedented grand master. And now this guy was his faithful guard.

Lloyd walked along with an odd feeling until he found himself in front of a shabby building.

"Where are we?"

"This is the pub."

"The pub?"

"Yes. You spend more time here than at your own home, Master Lloyd."

“So, this is where I’m a regular?”

“Of course. Unless you have been frequenting another place without my notice, that is.”

Good gracious. Inside his head, Lloyd was clicking his tongue.

He'd only been walking aimlessly, yet his feet brought him to his regular pub of all places. How often did he come here that even when possessed by another spirit, his body automatically found its way here? *Is this like a homing instinct? Am I a carrier pigeon? A spawning salmon? Or a lost dog that somehow travels a hundred miles back home?* He chastised the original owner of this body, the baron's eldest son.

He turned away. *Either way, I shouldn't be day drinking.* Lloyd might have enjoyed it, but Suho no longer did. Besides, he couldn't drink when he already had so much to figure out. He had no other thoughts besides that.

"Are we going back then?"

"Certainly," he answered Javier assuredly. However, Javier's reply was unexpected.

"In that case, what a disappointment."

"Huh…?"

"It is just as I said. You, Master Lloyd, are a disappointment."

"Were you really expecting me to indulge in some day drinking?"

"No."

"Then…?"

"I was under the impression that you were here to apologize and make restitutions for the chaos you caused here last night."

"So, you're disappointed I turned away?"

"That is correct. A nobleman has the duty to take on the responsibility that equals their status."

This punk has been throwing zingers all day. That one he just threw probably exceeded one hundred miles per hour. Javier had a strange talent for giving his helpful advice in a blunt and stinging way.

“The proprietor has been managing this pub his entire life… Even if it is a shabby old saloon. Last night, you caused a ruckus in this precious place and damaged the furniture here. Besides, as you may know, Master Lloyd, he’s caring for his elderly mother all on his own.”

“He is?”

“Yes. Her health has declined quite recently. The owner is gravely concerned.”

“So, I caused trouble for this poor fellow?”

“That is correct.”

It wasn’t even me who really did it. However, Javier continued to sting him.

“Actually, sir, he pleaded with me last night. He told me that, with his mother’s suffering in the winter cold and now the trouble you’ve caused, he’s deeply saddened and longs for death’s sweet embrace. You cannot turn a blind eye. After all, someday in the future, this estate will be under your care, Master Lloyd…”

“Hold on. Stop right there.”

With that, Javier’s speech was cut off. Was it because Lloyd couldn’t bear to hear any more? No. Javier’s words suddenly put an idea in his head.

“The owner’s mother suffers in the winter cold, you said?”

“That is what I said.”

“Then wouldn’t it do to have heated floors?”

“Sir?”

“Do the people here really…not know about heated flooring?” They really didn’t know; you could tell by the look in his eye. Something else popped into his head. *Come to think of it, even the bedroom in the baron’s house didn’t have heated floors.* He was a civil engineering student, so it was his habit to examine the structure of the buildings wherever he went. He could quickly analyze the construction of the baron’s house.

The baron’s had neither heated floors nor any kind of central heating system. Instead, a single fireplace occupied one side of the room. The pub owner’s home was likely the same design. Unlike the nobility, who would have a fireplace in every room, this man probably had a single fireplace to heat the entirety of his house.

It surely would be cold. Compared to a heated flooring system, a fireplace has a significant amount of heat loss.

Of course, heated floors weren’t without their cons. To get a heated flooring system, you’d have to either rebuild or entirely replace the floors. You must also insulate the building against heat loss. They likely consume a great amount of firewood here.

But those two cons… *They can be overcome. Well, actually, they can be taken advantage of. For me, it’s possible.*

If Lloyd made use of Suho’s college major, he would have a way of paying off the estate’s huge debt and escaping a bleak fate. With that incentive, he devised a plan that could make him tons of money.

He was certain. He could see it coming together.

This is it. It won’t end with the pub owner’s house. It’ll be even bigger! It will be a large-scale business. My chances of success are high indeed.

His mind was made up. The plans in his head would become a reality.

He took off straight toward the pub.

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Chapter 2: Model Home, Open House (1)

The inside of the pub was in shambles. Parts of broken tables and chairs were strewn all around, and the floor was littered with smashed dishes.

Gosh, I really did make a big mess.

Lloyd instinctively clicked his tongue when he saw the owner, trying to clean up the disaster that his pub had become.

The balding man had a bitter expression as he looked around at the chaos. As soon as the owner glanced Lloyd's way, his face became pale, and then flushed with anger. His anger diminished quickly, however, and was replaced by an awkward smile. It was the forced smile of a poor man made to continue doing business at his tavern.

"Uh, welcome…?"

Thinking about what happened last night surely curdles his blood, Lloyd thought. It went without saying. Seeing him that way made Lloyd lose his appetite, reminding him of his past as Suho Kim. Those memories flooded his mind. *There were plenty of terrible customers when I worked at the Hope Pub.* He had many part-time jobs, and working at the Hope was one of them. Since it was a bar, there were all sorts of customers—bad ones among them.

Actually, there were a whole lot of them. It was a given that once they were drunk, they'd verbally harass the part-time staff. Some of them went so far as to break bottles and flip tables; complaining that the prices were too high, the snacks weren't to their liking, or the employees weren't polite enough. They'd swing their broken bottles and demand to see the manager.

Sigh.

He sighed a lot back then. Such was the plight of a part-timer. Nothing could be said to the VIP customers. He was forced to restrain his boiling rage when they would get rowdy.

Let's stop thinking about that.

They were bitter memories, but Lloyd fully empathized with the pub owner's feelings because of them. Although…he wasn't really the one who had done this. The original Lloyd had torn this pub apart.

He faced the pub owner and gave him a heartfelt apology. "I'm here to tell you that I am sorry for what happened last night."

"What…?"

"I've done you wrong. I should've drunk quietly and kept to myself instead of causing a big mess. I won't make excuses. It was entirely my fault."

Despite putting his heart into these words, the intended sincerity did not carry over well.

"Um, young master? What are you saying?" The pallor of the owner's face turned a pale blue as if he'd seen a ghost. "Master, were you not satisfied with last night's business? Please tell me, what did I do wrong?"

"No, I…"

"Why are you being so polite to me? That's even more frightening."

The people of the manor truly loathed him, it seemed. Lloyd smacked his lips and responded, "Is talking casually like this much better?"

"O-of course, sir."

"Do you accept my apology then? I'm thinking of compensating you for the broken items."

"Do you really mean it, sir?"

The poor bloke must've been lied to his whole life. Lloyd clicked his tongue and said, "Of course I mean it! How about a heated flooring system as compensation?"

“Huh?”

“A room with warm, heated floors. Haven’t you heard of that?”

“I’ve heard of heating a stone and sprinkling water on it, but…”

“That’s a steam sauna. I’m talking about the floor itself being heated. A heated flooring system, you know?” Of course, he didn’t know. Just like Javier a moment ago, the pub owner was speechless. His plans were indeed possible. Lloyd licked his lips. “It’s a shame you haven’t heard of it. Your mother would really enjoy it.”

“Excuse me?”

“I’ve heard that your mother is ill.”

“Oh, yes. That is true.”

“Then I recommend heated flooring. It makes the floors warm. You won’t even need a bed. Just lie down on the heated floor, and it will keep you comfortable all day! A sauna can’t even compare.”

He was becoming convinced. Bit by bit, the owner was being won over. But Lloyd could see him wavering, so he took it one step further. “It’s perfect for the elderly and their aching joints in mid-winter when their body gets a chill.”

“Elders like my mother?”

“Indeed.”

It has been true since the beginning of time that older people enjoy keeping warm.

“So, you’re saying that you will give me this, young master?”

“Uh-huh. I’ll build a proper one for you.”

“You’ll make it yourself?”

“Uh-huh.”

“You don’t believe me?”

“Um, well…”

“Of course, you wouldn’t. After all the ruckus I caused, you think I’m pulling your leg. You’re wondering, who do I think I am, offering to make some fantastic heated floors for you. You wonder if such a thing actually even exists. Yet, as you listen, you can’t help but think of your mother. It catches your ear and draws you in. Am I right?”

The pub owner still hesitated.

“Fine, then let’s draw up a contract.”

“A contract?”

“Yup. A construction contract.”

“But…”

“Bring me a pen and paper.”

The confusion on the owner’s face was obvious, but he quickly presented Lloyd with a pen and some paper. Swiftly and skillfully, Lloyd drew up a contract.

If it’s a form I need, I can make it myself. The pub owner is the client. I am the contractor. The construction site is the vacant lot behind the pub, etc.

“Let’s arrange compensation like this… The construction project will cover the costs for all the damage I inflicted on your property last night. What do you think?”

“Are you saying that…instead of paying for the damage, you will install this elaborate heated flooring as reimbursement?”

“That’s right,” Lloyd nodded.

Since the baron was in debt, he was in no position to offer financial compensation. However, if he completed this project successfully from start to finish… *This way, I can take care of the reimbursement neatly, while also entirely avoiding accumulating further liability.* Not only would this fix his debt problem, but, if all went well, he could make a great deal of money too. This would become the starting point for accumulating wealth instead. That was the big picture Lloyd envisioned.

This is what I do best.

He had studied quite hard in college. He never had any big dreams, of course. He'd selected his civil engineering major based on test scores and assessments, just like everybody else. He did his best to get good grades so that he could snag a stable job. But maybe, just maybe, all the knowledge he accumulated could be used here.

Real estate is always a big money maker—the construction part of it may be more so.

Whether it was apartment blocks, office buildings, bridges, roads, dams, marinas, canals, or ports… All of it was profitable! Construction meant big money, and the larger the project, the truer that was. Lloyd relished in the possibilities of his plan.

"Now, let's sign the contract. What do you think?"

"Then…you're serious?"

"I'm going to build this myself. You don't want it?"

"N-no, that's not it."

Despite his hesitation, the pub owner ultimately signed the contract, with Suho Kim — a South Korean civil engineering student; and Lloyd Frontera — the eldest son of Baron Arcos Frontera.

It was their first work order in this strange world. Although it was a small one. This was to be the first of many steps. With this began his great

construction project.

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Javier had been silent this whole time. Barely a minute after they left the bar he suddenly spoke up. “He’s a naive and desperate man.”

“What do you mean by that?” Lloyd looked back to see Javier’s expression was the same as always. It actually seemed colder than before.

“When a person is cornered, they become desperate. Their perspective narrows and their judgment is blurred. Those people become easy prey for those with guile in their souls.”

“Prey?”

“Yes sir.”

“Ah, so you’re saying the pub owner is the pitiful prey, and I’m the dastardly villain?”

“Whether or not you are dastardly will be judged by your behavior from now on, sir.”

“Hey!”

He felt that the mood had become colder than before. Lloyd finally realized what Javier was thinking.

“Do you think I’m trying to scam the pub owner?”

“No, sir.”

“Then?”

“I think you’re taking advantage of a very vulnerable person.”

…*That’s the same thing.* Lloyd let out a long sigh. Since entering this body, everything he did seemed to be misunderstood.

“Let’s get this straight. You think I have no intention of constructing a heated flooring system for him, right?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Why not?”

“Because you’re someone who has never once gotten their hands dirty.”

“How would you know that?”

“I’ve heard things…here and there.”

“But you’ve never seen for yourself, have you?”

“That is true.”

“Javier. You are less reasonable than you appear.”

“Excuse me?”

Javier’s sculpted brow frowned ever so slightly, for possibly the first time ever. Lloyd—a mere two inches shorter—looked up at him and said, “I’m disappointed, Javier. Do you judge others based solely on rumor?”

“That’s…”

“It’s prejudice. Oh yes. It still is. You saw me draw up a contract with the owner of that pub. What did you think I might do with that?”

“Surely…”

“You thought I’d ball it up and toss it into a corner, didn’t you?”

“That is not true.”

Not true? He had hit the nail on the head. Lloyd noticed earlier that Javier was a terrible liar. Whenever he lied, he wouldn’t look at you. Just. Like. Now.

“You thought I was pulling a fast one on that guy, with the contract as a smokescreen. That I’d indefinitely put off building the heated floors, and never repay the owner for the damages.”

“I just…”

“That’s called prejudice. Blindly judging people with only your opinion to go on. This causes conflicts to arise! Racial discrimination runs rampant! Homes to be shaken, and society to collapse!”

Javier didn’t anticipate such a response. He shut his mouth. He probably thought it was all a bit of chicanery. But Lloyd didn’t try to change his mind. Instead, he motioned to Javier with his chin. “Hmm… Anyway, since I have a general idea of what you’re thinking, why don’t you step aside.”

“Excuse me?”

“Just two steps to the side. Yes, to that side. I’m trying to take a preliminary survey right now.”

It was true. Even before Javier had opened his mouth. This backyard was where he was going to build this house with heated floors. It was of utmost importance to inspect the site before drafting the design and procuring the construction materials. *I’m going to make it small, so I won’t need super-precise measurements. But the land is slightly uneven. I’ll have to raise one side just a bit.*

One side of the site reached up to the pub, and the opposite side was where the pub owner’s house was located. He figured placing the heated room between the two would be a good idea.

Let’s look at the ground. Lloyd knelt and looked at the soil of the building site. He touched it and then squeezed it. *Ah, reminds me of college.*

As he reached into the dirt, memories of soil mechanics class resurfaced. Studying the soil’s volume. Its gaps. He’d scooped up so many different types of turf before. There was so much more to it. He’d roll up the bits of dirt like eraser shreds. He would roll it until it broke down. He’d put the

clods in ovens to bake them, roast them, or steam them. Now all this accumulated knowledge was waiting there to help Lloyd out.

This dirt will do. The soil quality wasn't merely okay. Under the surface, a few centimeters down, was reddish soil. It was red clay. *Amazing!*

Lloyd brushed off his hands as he stood up, then met Javier's curious gaze. "What? You've never seen anyone touch dirt before?"

"I've never seen you do this before, sir."

"Then get used to it. You'll see it often enough from now on."

Javier's eyes reflected a deeper curiosity, but Lloyd ignored it and walked on. He left the site and wandered about the manor. Although he strolled leisurely, Lloyd's gaze was occupied with surveying the land. He focused on a river that ran through the center of town… This seemed like a good place to collect red clay for his project.

"Alright, let's head home."

When he returned home, his work did not cease. This was to be his monumental first construction project. *They say it's the first step that counts the most.*

It takes just one wrong move to earn a bad reputation. After that, it would be harder to find his next customer. He would be doomed from the start. It was imperative that he did his best to create a high-quality end product to avoid that.

A customer's happiness is my wealth.

He stayed up all night. Schoolwork and part-time jobs had trained him for this moment. From sundown until sunup, he filled many sheets of paper with floor plans. As soon as it was daylight, he set off to find the manor administrator.

"How much lumber do we have in storage?"

“Excuse me?”

It was very early in the morning. The administrator hadn’t eaten breakfast or washed up yet. He tilted his head to one side. He was probably wondering if Lloyd was already drunk this early in the day. “What do you intend to use this wood for, sir?”

“What do you think? I’m using it to build a structure. See, here.”

“This?”

“Collect the amount of timber I’ve noted down here. Transport it to the back of the pub. Understood?”

If you’re going to do a job, might as well get it done swiftly and boldly like a bulldozer. That was how Lloyd approached this project. The administrator nodded indifferently. The order of lumber was stacked behind the pub by lunchtime.

“With my materials in place, I can begin!”

He removed his cumbersome coat and now wore only a light shirt and heavy workman’s gloves. The shovel was a welcome weight in his hands.

Even on vacation, I was doing this sort of work.

It was the same when he was in the army. Majoring in civil engineering, jobs both big and small were always assigned to him. By the time he was discharged, he was treated as their personal work machine.

It’s a man’s lot in life to always be behind a shovel.

It began with leveling and packing the ground beside the garden, where the heated room was to be built. Carefully, but firmly, he continued to stomp down the dirt.

If you move the dirt all at once and build the foundation, there will be a big problem later.

It was a common mistake when hardening the soil. The upper part is easily made firm, but underneath…? Not so much. So, if you moved and hardened a lot of dirt all at once… To the naked eye, the surface would look solid, but the inside would still be too soft. Then, if you built something on top of it… After a few years passed, the building would lean and cause a disaster.

Knowing all of this, Lloyd scooped up the dirt and packed it over and over again. As he worked, he suddenly noticed Javier. That punk had been standing off to one side for some time now. He was probably just faithfully fulfilling his duty as a guard.

“Hey, you.”

“You called for me, Sir Lloyd?”

“Yes, I did.”

“Do you have orders for me?”

“Hmm, I do. Come shovel with me.”

Javier made no reply.

“You don’t want to? Is that it?”

“If you help me, the job will get done twice as quickly.”

“Ah, I bet the pub owner’s mother is suffering from the chills right now. If she could rest in a room with heated floors, her aches would probably disappear in an instant. But for now, that’s impossible! Why? Because the holier-than-thou Sir Javier refuses to pick up a shovel.”

“Oh, if only she could soothe her body in a heated room. Her joint pain would subside, and she would wear a huge smile on her face. But for now, she can’t. Why? Because the almighty Lord Javier refuses to shovel.”

“Ah, for the simple final wish of someone who doesn’t have long to live…”

“Please just give me a shovel…”

In the end, Javier couldn’t take it anymore and grabbed a shovel. A devilish grin spread across Lloyd’s face. With that, the baron’s little monster and the future knight worked together, and the site for the room with the heated floor was well on its way. News of this work spread instantly to every corner of the realm.

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Chapter 3: Model Home, Open House (2)

The rumors spread. They spread very quickly. It was true that rumors would always exist wherever people lived. Even so, this gossip was more noteworthy than usual, and it spread that much faster as this was something new and unexpected.

“Master Lloyd has finally lost his senses.”

“What?”

“I heard he’s been shoveling.”

“What do you mean?”

“Just like I said, he’s behind the pub, with a shovel, digging. He’s scooping up dirt, and then flattening it.”

“For what?”

“I don’t really know. According to what I heard, he threatened the pub owner.”

“Threatened him?”

“He seems to be claiming the land in the back of the pub for himself.”

“Haha, that’s…”

Everyone around the table continued to malign Lloyd. Out in the gardens, others whispered among themselves too.

“Did you hear? Master Lloyd tried to kill himself.”

“What, finally?”

“That’s what they said. He was digging yesterday, and today he’s doing it again.”

“He’s digging?”

“He’s scooping up dirt then placing flat stones in its place, all while mumbling something to himself.”

“Could it be…”

“Is he digging his own grave?”

Speculation ran rampant in the village. Was he burying a large supply of liquor? Perhaps he was digging a tunnel to keep out of his father’s sight? Some even thought he’d discovered a wild new fetish. A crowd of villagers had heard the rumors and gathered around the site to see for themselves. As they watched, the heated floor gradually took shape.

***

People here sure know how to talk, Lloyd thought as he wiped the sweat dripping from his brow.

He got mud on his face doing this but did not care. Then he took a look around. The room was small, only about twelve square feet. In just a few days, not only had he set the foundation but also built the walls. *That was difficult.*

Lloyd already expected that making a heated flooring system wouldn’t be easy. After actually doing it himself, it was even harder than he imagined. First of all, he didn’t have the same tools as when he was out working on projects in Korea. *I don’t even have a single power tool.*

Everything needed to be done by hand. He used his experiences working in construction and in the army to build the foundation. The process took two full days, and his whole body ached in return.

The wood taken from the baron’s lumber yard was trimmed, and the basic structure was made up of this heavy timber. The gabled roofs were erected, and beams were placed between the pillars for reinforcement. Then, a sticky

plaster of red clay and straw was applied. Just like that, the red clay walls were completed in three days.

“Whew. Javier?”

“Sir?”

“Aren’t you tired?”

“I’ve grown accustomed to it, sir.”

“Really?”

Despite how good his athletic abilities were, construction work was another matter entirely. However, Javier wasn’t breathing hard at all. *It probably takes a lot of energy to work muscles that aren’t normally used. Yet, why is he so composed? The amount of strength he has must be on a whole different level.* Lloyd was in awe of his steely, top-condition stamina. Javier was certainly a reliable guy, especially when he was working for free like this.

Lloyd tested his luck using a gracious tone.

“Okay, then try doing what I tell you to.”

“There is more to do?”

“Of course.”

“How so?”

“The heated flooring hasn’t been completed yet.”

“But you only asked me to help for a little while.”

“Did I?”

“Yes sir,” Javier replied curtly in his characteristic cold tone. “First you asked me to help you shovel, saying that would be all. But your

requirements kept changing. After finishing compacting the soil, you asked for help with the wood. Later you said that removing the mud was too hard and you asked for my help again."

"Hmm, so were you upset?"

"Of course, sir."

"Because you're a knight?"

Javier didn't reply, but the silence suggested the affirmative. It made sense, though. Instead of a sword, he was handling a shovel and saw while covered in dirt. He probably thought this kind of work was below the honor of a knight such as himself. But Lloyd found a weakness in Javier's line of thought.

"I was thinking, isn't a knight someone who helps the weak?"

"Excuse me?"

"You probably think so too."

"Well, that's…"

"Right? Then this work is also part of a knight's duty. Helping the weak is great practice in the chivalric arts. Wouldn't you say so? At this very moment, the pub owner's mom is probably shivering with chills. If we could even finish this just one day sooner, could you imagine the delighted cheer that would erupt from his poor elderly mother's lips…"

"What must I do now?" Javier sighed deeply.

With an impish smile, Lloyd said, "Split some wood for me."

He pointed outside. "See those logs in the corner out there behind the pub?"

"I see them."

“Okay, good. That’s red pine. Chop them up with an ax to make panels for the roof.”

“What are panels?”

Lloyd scratched a rough drawing of the panels on the ground and said, “They look like this.”

“Make them one span in width, two in length, and about a finger’s height in thickness. Think of it as a longer version of a tablet… oh, you don’t know what a tablet is, do you? Just think of it as a board and cut them all the same size. Understood?”

“Then wouldn’t the saw be better than the ax to cut with?”

“No, no. The ax is better.” Of course, cutting was easier with the saw. It was easier to cut them all the same size that way, too. However, sawing causes severe wear and tear, which could ruin the wood grain. Moisture can seep in and cause rotting in no time. “Unless you’d like to replace the roof in less than a year, use the ax.”

“Understood, but…”

“But?”

Now that Lloyd had his attention, Javier was staring at him with a curious expression.

“Master Lloyd, where did you learn all this?”

“All this? You mean building construction?”

“Yes sir.” His gaze was still frigid, but a glimmer of emotion was hidden beneath his opaque exterior. That feeling was one of intense curiosity.

Lloyd replied with honesty and openness, “Korea University.”

“Excuse me?”

“I learned about it at Korea University. It’s true. I’m not lying.”

“But I’ve never heard of such an academy.”

“Ah, surely you haven’t heard that I attended school somewhere, either?”

“Yes sir.”

“Then keep wondering. Now, let’s move. We have a lot to do, so let’s get working.”

Lloyd waved his hand and ushered Javier outside. Javier was much better at cutting the roof panels than he was. He just had a natural talent. Whether his target was a person or a tree, Javier was best at slicing it in half with a blade.

This punk’s already a top-rank swordsman.

The Knight of Blood and Iron mentioned this early in the novel. It was something no one in the Frontera barony knew yet, not even the baron or Javier himself. Javier was already phenomenally talented. He was close to being a senior swordsman. A provost. Because the nation was small and had only a handful of people of that caliber, it meant he could be commander of a decent size kingdom. *And he’s barely even twenty years old.*

Only when he departs the baron’s lands does Javier realize the amazing potential he has. But that is yet to come. *Anyway, I better keep moving.*

Lloyd rested a little, and then they began the next step.

It was the alpha and omega of the heating system. It was the bread and jam. Its existence was as crucial as HD graphics are to AAA computer games. “It” was the floor. *This job just became real.*

You can make a building as properly as possible, but it’s useless if the heating system didn't work. Lloyd knew this well and did his best to concentrate. *It’ll go from here to there, as planned…*

He'd done this back in the army too. There was a time when a commander got hooked on dry saunas, and Lloyd was commissioned to build one for the regional headquarters. How did it turn out? The happiness of the commander's wife increased dramatically. Because of this success, Lloyd was rewarded vacation time by the commander himself.

Lloyd was making full use of his experiences and memories. First: he dug into the floor. There had to be a passage for the heat and smoke from the furnace to flow. *The passages must be circular in order to distribute the heat's path along the entire floor.*

He dug the passages in a winding pattern. While doing so, he didn't forget to carefully decrease the height of the passageway as well. *This way, the heat won't escape all at once, and it'll remain for as long as possible.*

He made an opening where the initial flow of heat emerged from the furnace and a raised retainer wall where the heat was trapped before the smoke leaves through the chimney flue. The passages channeled the heat, so it flowed efficiently under the floor. A cover on the chimney top was placed last to block any rainwater or cold air from coming in.

This is hard.

He meticulously double-checked the work as he dug to minimize errors. He checked and adjusted, over and over again. Then he finished off the passage walls with red clay and let it dry completely. Above the passages, he carefully placed flat stones.

At the upper end of the passage neck — close to the furnace — I'll put heavy stones. At the opposite end where the lower neck is, I'll put lighter stones. He methodically sorted the stones and placed them in this way because the lower neck, being farther away from the furnace, was slower to heat up. Decreasing the thickness of the stones closer to the lower neck meant being able to evenly distribute heat throughout the entire floor.

Time to fill in the gaps.

He filled the space between the flat stones with gravel and then applied more red clay on top. Again, he placed dried mud and stomped on it to make it firm. He leveled the ground once more to make it flat as possible, then allowed it to dry thoroughly. Afterward, by sanding the surface and applying a light finish, it was complete. So far, it had taken three whole days.

The main part of the heating system was finished but putting it to the test would have to wait.

“Excuse me, young master?”

Just as he was standing there admiring his work, one of the servants walked in.

“Lord Frontera is looking for you.”

Lord Frontera, meaning Arcos Frontera, the baron. His father.

No way. He suddenly realized something…

Lloyd left the unfinished room, and the crowd that had been chattering nearby stopped its whispering at once. Passing through that awkward silence, Lloyd set off for the baron’s mansion.

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“Apparently there’s a strange rumor going around these days.”

Clack.

His fork picked up a homemade sausage, but the baron’s hand stopped moving. The fork never made it to his mouth. His gaze turned toward the opposite end of the table.

“What are you doing behind that pub?”

His look held no warmth and, frankly, appeared unfeeling. It was more like he was looking at a burden than his own son. It put a bitter taste in Lloyd’s

mouth.

This is the downside to being in this body. The owner of this body he found himself within, Lloyd Frontera, was a consummate brute. All he was known for was his binge drinking, gambling, and vandalism. He had quite an extensive record and his bad karma had piled up. So, he was the target of the prejudices of the people around him.

For instance, no matter what he did, people looked at him warily. They wondered what mischief that brute was up to, or what commotion he was going to cause this time. Maybe he was crazy, or maybe it was his time to die. If only he would stop bothering those around him…was what those looks seemed to say. The current situation was no different.

“Let’s hear it. What are you up to this time?”

The baron’s voice was colder than his eyes. As soon as he heard it, Lloyd knew it wasn’t a question — it was a rebuke.

Lloyd shrugged and said, “If you’ve heard the rumors, then you must already know. I’m making the heated flooring system the pub owner ordered.”

“A heated flooring system?”

“Yes.”

“So not only are you making empty promises to the pub owner, but you are even trying to deceive your own father?”

“I can’t help if you think of it that way.”

Lloyd beat around the bush. He didn’t know what he could say at this point that would be believable. It seemed easier to create more pointless misunderstandings. No matter, it felt weird to even try convincing the baron in front of him. It was just awkward. *If I talk too much, I might get caught.*

Parents will recognize their own children in one way or another. He wasn’t actually Lloyd Frontera. He was Suho Kim, currently the occupant of

Lloyd’s body. He was anxious that they would suspect him, so he decided to avoid long conversations.

“If that’s all you wished to say, I’ll finish my meal now,” he said. Just as Lloyd would have, he cut the conversation short and focused on the food, only thinking to stuff himself full and leave before anything else could be said.

Then the baron posed another question. “Is it due to family matters? You’re aware of recent events. You know about what’s happened. Perhaps it has upset you enough that you’re doing this on purpose?”

Likely he was referring to the seizure of their property. As expected, his suspicion was correct.

“It’s fine. Merely a passing storm. Not much will come of it. After all, I am Arcos Frontera, the fifth baron of this estate. Your father can handle this much trouble like nothing, so try not to get in my way. I’m telling you I can handle it, so do not get worked up over it.”

He’d heard this kind of thing before. Suddenly, Lloyd raised his head and looked right at the baron. The baron was a handsome middle-aged man, but his expression was tired. That expression was just like the one he’d seen on his own father’s face.

It’s just like back then. It was the last vacation during his time in the army. His father had the same look on his face after falling for an investment scam. Abruptly, he clasped his hands and said, *“Don’t worry, it’ll be fine. It’s nothing, just worry about studying.”*

He pleaded and forced a smile, so Suho didn’t know a thing. Suho truly thought everything would be fine. He didn’t have a clue that, one year later, his parents would make a drastic decision because they couldn’t escape from the burden of debt. And now the baron sitting in front of him had that same expression on his face.

Lies.

It wasn’t fine. He was just forcing himself to appear fine in front of his son.

Clink.

Lloyd set his fork down. Long gone were his thoughts of focusing merely on eating, and he momentarily forgot about keeping his distance from the baron. He found himself speaking without realizing it. “Don’t give up, I’ll help too.” Those were the words he wished to say to his father years ago if he could go back in time.

With that, he quietly stood up. The baron stared at him peculiarly. His frigid stare from before now held a slightly different cast. His stare felt heavy, so Lloyd hurried to leave.

Thankfully, the baron didn’t stop him.

***

The construction continued. The heated flooring system in the pub owner’s yard was quickly taking shape. There were groups of spectators gathering around. He charred the panels as they watched intently, formulating their misunderstandings, murmurs, and rumors.

It was a treatment to prevent the wood from rotting through carbonization. He ruined a few at first since he wasn’t used to it. Some burned so much that they split, and others were too soft. However, he started to get the hang of it after a few tries. The trick was to scorch only the top three millimeters of the red pine panels.

Just perfect.

The panels were lightweight, yet hard, so water couldn’t easily penetrate them. *They should be good even ten years later.*

He layered the panels onto the roof, then carefully rolled out the paper lining and covered up the clay floor. A heftier paper was placed on top of that using a thick paste. He applied soybean oil on top of that, then finished off the waterproofing with a layer of resin.

The heated flooring was complete.

To test it out, he lit a flame and felt the floor.

“It’s done.”

A grin flashed across his face. Now, it was time to check out his customer’s reaction.

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Chapter 4: Model Home, Open House (3)

“It’s quite…warm,” she said, as her wrinkled hand caressed the floor. With curiosity, at first, she pressed her palm down and then flipped it to brush the floor with her knuckles. Surprise suddenly filled her face. She tossed the cushion aside and plopped herself down on the toasty-warm floor. A smile of satisfaction curved across the white-haired woman’s face.

“So nice…so very nice.”

The elderly lady was a little senile, so her words were very direct. Hearing her approval, the pub owner looked at Lloyd. His face, too, was filled with a smile of gratitude. “My mother loves it, young master.”

“Does she?”

“Yes.”

“Just like I told you, this heated flooring system is very comforting,” Lloyd said with a shrug. He was just relieved that it was such a huge success.

It was still very early spring, and the morning air was crisp. Outside held the chill of the final cold snap. Inside was different. The fire was lit, the floor was toasty warm, and the air was relaxing. The pub owner was relieved to be removing his coat.

“You saw me light the fire earlier, right? All you have to do is start up the furnace outside the door. If you light it once like that, the heat will last about two days. That’s it. It really doesn’t cool off as quickly as you might think.”

“Two days, you said?” Once lit, the heat lasted two days. The pub owner’s eyes became wide with wonder.

Smiling, Lloyd said, “Test it out and see if what I said is true.”

“I…I definitely believe you.”

“Really?”

"Yes. Um, may I be honest?”

“Go right ahead.”

“I really thought you were trying to fool me, sir.”

“Me? Fool you?”

“Yes. I never imagined you would actually build this for me.”

Well, that was understandable. Just a little reminder: Lloyd Frontera was a complete and utter bastard. He’d never done anything for anyone else in his life. It wasn’t in his nature. No wonder the pub owner didn’t trust him.

“I had no faith in this, but you have given us such a great floor, of such warmth. I swear, I’ve never seen such a thing in my life.”

“Really?”

“Yes. My mother loves it so much. I don’t know how to express my thanks to you. Praise be the heated floor!”

I hope someone else can see this! Everyone is praising the magnificence of this classic Korean design! Lloyd coughed nervously and replied, “Ahem, no need to thank me. It was just for the contract.”

“Ah, the contract.”

“Yeah. Right. The contract.”

It was a mere transaction carried out through mutual agreement. Lloyd constructed the heated floor, and that would reimburse the pub owner for the damages inflicted.

“However, I think the cost of this heated floor is greater than the cost of what was broken. Sir, please wait here for a moment.” Lloyd had no idea

what the tavern keeper was thinking as he promptly stood up. He returned shortly with a leather pouch in his hand.

“Please, take this.”

“What is it?”

“A small token of my extreme gratitude.”

Clunk. The pouch fell with a heavy metallic sound. There were coins inside.

“Oh my…you didn’t have to…”

Lloyd took up the pouch without hesitation. He then offered more advice on the heated floor’s use as a thank you. “See this window here? On a chilly night, leave this window slightly open at dawn to let in the cold air. Then, fire up the furnace to the max, and cover the floor with a blanket. Wrap some tangerines, roasted potatoes, or sweet potatoes in it to eat. Do you know what will happen next?”

“No. What will happen?”

“The air will be fresh, and your bottom will be warm. You’ll be like a fish at the confluence of warm and cold streams, as their currents converge.”

The pub owner tilted his head to one side, while, with a farewell wave, Lloyd left the room. There was a large group of spectators gathered nearby. They were still looking his way as they jabbered amongst themselves. Their faces held a mixture of some surprise and much doubt.

But of course. A laugh escaped him.

He thought of all the rumors about him that were swirling about: That he was unstable; that he was digging a grave for when he killed himself; that he was swindling the pub owner. There wasn’t a single good rumor!

And yet, before them all, sat a functional heated flooring system. All those convoluted rumors were shattered before their eyes.

Now they'll be even more curious. They'll wonder what kind of building has been made, what it's for, and why the pub owner likes it so much. They'll have no clue about anything.

Lloyd stood back and let the rumors fly. He had no reason to stop them. In fact, it's actually a good thing. *It's like free advertising!*

Publicity was important. It was life! That was the case for contractors too. This was even more true in South Korea. The smallest apartment began with a big promotion.

Broadcasting, billboards, and infomercials: these were just the basics. Other obvious options included, but were not limited to, social media, targeted search-based results, and viral videos. Reach the people by any means necessary!

That way I can take advantage of widespread promotions, while also muting any criticism. Then, when I open the model house, people will flock to it like seagulls.

As a result, there would be a whole line of contract requests, and it would become a proper business, or so Lloyd hoped.

These rumors drew a crowd here without me having to spend a dime. This is a unique opportunity. There were probably well over a hundred villagers looking his way and murmuring. But Lloyd didn't see the people of the estate. He saw potential contracts. He saw customers that were lining up to hand him their money.

The model house is now open. He stood before the crowd, the focus of all their attention. He cleared his throat and began, "Are you all wondering what it is I've made here?"

As he expected, no one replied. They all only kept their eyes fixed squarely on him. Lloyd smiled. Not bad. All was going as planned.

This would be a short, and rewarding, sales pitch.

“Come in, one by one, and take a look for yourselves!”

Lloyd approached the crowd carefully. He took a woman in front by the sleeve, and led her into the room, even as her face paled in concern.

Ladies first. It was they who started the rumors, after all.

With the pub owner’s permission, they began the tour. The woman’s eyes grew wide as she experienced the comfort of the warm flooring. After that, the rest was a breeze. The other gawkers took turns looking around and became converted to the benefits of a heated floor.

As they entered, their smug faces became ones of envy. Lloyd greeted them from a table he had set up; installation contracts spread out before him.

“Now that you’ve experienced it, what do you think?”

“It’s…it’s much nicer than I expected.”

“It is, isn’t it?”

“Yes. I don’t think we’ll have to worry about the winter cold anymore.”

“That’s why I’ve prepared this ahead of time. Would you like to take a look?”

“This here?”

“This is a blueprint. It’s a kind of plan.”

Lloyd had stayed up all night drafting lovingly hand-drawn pamphlets that demonstrated two styles of heated flooring systems. These he handed out to the people.

“Type A is the one you see here, where the heated floor is built in a separate building in the yard. Type B involves tearing up your existing floor on the ground level and remodeling it. If you order both, you’ll receive a ten percent discount. You have kids at home, right?”

“Yes. My oldest is seven, and the youngest is five.”

“In the winter, doesn’t it bring tears to your eyes to watch your children shiver and cough in the cold? Doesn’t it pain you to see them huddle in front of the fireplace to keep warm? Even the very thought must be heart-wrenching. If you sign a contract now, I’ll give you a special deal where you receive five free bundles of firewood. Consider wisely. This chance doesn’t come by every day.”

“Well, even so…”

“What, you don’t want to?”

The man clamped his mouth shut. Lloyd understood how he felt. *It’s because he doesn’t trust me. Or maybe he’s just afraid.*

It made sense, after all. He may be a different person, but these people were unaware of it. To them, he was the same old Lloyd Frontera, the scourge of the barony—human trash that was best at drinking and mayhem.

I can’t expect them to suddenly believe in me after showing them just one good deed.

Perhaps they thought it was all a con, or that he was fooling around, so they hesitated to sign a contract. He had already expected as much.

“So? You won’t sign a contract? Really, is that how you’re going to be?”

The man flinched as Lloyd stared at him intently. He’d already figured out the meaning behind the man’s gaze. *He probably thinks I’ll make his life here difficult if he doesn’t sign the contract right now. He’s wracked with anxiety.* Lloyd stifled a bitter smile. Using the discomfort and fear of the villagers felt like a cheap shot. But for now, it was the best plan.

It won’t hurt to take advantage of my despicable reputation every now and then. It’s not like I’m going to take off with their down payments and never build a single thing.

This launch was the most important thing. He had to obtain signed contracts no matter what. After that, he was confident that good word of mouth would make it all happen. For now, he had to lowball and make good use of Lloyd's notoriety.

Another customer: "Ah… I understand." He was rationalizing between being conned and avoiding an oncoming disaster. The man signed the contract with some hesitation. It was the same for the next and the next and the next. Naturally, Lloyd was confident that he could brighten those faces soon enough.

That's just how efficiently the heated flooring system works. That was his conclusion based on his investigations over the past few days. The current fireplace systems in the area had limitations.

Contrary to appearances, a fireplace is not as efficient as it looks. It only heats what's close by, and because it only warms the air, it cools off quickly. The heat doesn't stay inside for long. Additionally, ash and smoke burn the eyes. *It's hard to care for since you can't use just any firewood. To keep the light and heat from going out, one person must stay up all night to watch over it.*

His heated flooring system on the other hand? It created a balanced system, as Lloyd continued to confidently persuade the villagers. Before the afternoon had come to a close, Lloyd had secured thirty-two contracts type-A and fifty-seven contracts type-B. This provided him with a hefty sum of deposits.

Awesome!

It wasn't a whole lot of money, of course, and he didn't have anywhere near enough to settle the baron's debt. However, it was from here going forward that was important.

Although it was all a bit forced, when I complete these heated floors to their satisfaction, good news will come of it. Then I'll even be able to branch out to other regions. Branding the heated flooring system and building a business around it in this region was Lloyd's primary goal.

Whew, he finished up the final contract and let out a sigh. Then, he took a look around at the red-tinted sunset that he hadn't admired before. He turned away and saw Javier headed in his direction.

"Hey, you. You're strong, right?"

"Yes, I suppose so."

"Then what do you think of being a human crane or forklift?"

"Sir?"

"You said you're strong. Could you use that strength to dig up the ground and lug logs?"

It was a sincere request. Javier was an incredible knight. Certainly, his strength surpassed that of human limitations. If Javier were to do the heavy lifting? His future construction projects would become much simpler and speedier. Efficiency would increase. At the same time, he could take on more projects and greatly increase his income.

However, Javier shook his head without hesitation. "I cannot."

"Why not?"

"Because the baron has given me the mission of your personal protection."

"So, he wouldn't allow you to be a construction worker?"

"That is correct."

"But you've helped me up until now."

"That's because, as a knight, I thought it was my duty to assist the pub owner's elderly mother."

"Protection of the weak?"

"Yes. However, the request you've just made is different."

“You won’t help me with my business?”

“That is correct.”

“You’re certain of this?”

“Indeed.”

Of course, he would be the resolute type. Lloyd smacked his lips. *But still, I definitely need heavy equipment.*

The difference between having and not having the equipment meant a construction period of up to ten times longer. Even the type of construction options that were possible would change.

If I want to make big money, I’ve got to build on a larger scale.

He was satisfied with heated floors for now, but he wanted to surpass that level at some point. The amount of money he could make with just that was limited.

I don’t want to be paying back debt until I’m at a ripe old age, he worried.

His life in Korea was topsy-turvy because of money, and he really didn’t want to live that way here too.

So, if I intend to pay this whole debt off with a construction company, I have to figure out this heavy equipment issue.

He pondered deeply on this for the entire way back home. Yet Lloyd couldn’t come up with anything. Javier’s cold eyes stared at him; his look had seemingly changed from before.

***

I’m at a loss for words. Javier was quite flustered as he followed behind Lloyd. Lloyd Frontera was the eldest son of his master, Lord Frontera. He had been in charge of escorting him for the past few months, which disconcerted him even more. *Was this alky always like this?*

Lloyd was a total scumbag — not just in the opinion of the most conservative fellows, but also in the view of the average person. He had no patience, and one could expect neither manners nor refinement from him. He was merely a worthless booze hound, constantly guzzling alcohol.

The day of the foreclosure on his family's home was no different.

Honestly, I hated him. Well, I still do.

The more he got to know him, the more he was unlikeable. If he weren't his master's son, he probably would've already sliced him up. Although Javier was escorting him, he despised his existence. To him, Lloyd was nothing but human garbage.

But suddenly, he's different now.

It was a few days ago, the morning of the day after he caused a scene at his regular pub. Javier still clearly remembered what Lloyd was like that morning. *I barely had to call him twice to wake him up.* That was unimaginable before. The scoundrel even remembered and called Javier's name for the first time. But that was just the beginning.

He sought out the pub owner to appease him, and instead of monetary compensation, he promised to make him a heated floor. Up until that point, Javier thought he was just up to some more shifty mischief. However, that was not the case. He actually built the heated floor and kept his promise to the pub owner.

It didn't stop there. Lloyd even drew up contracts for all the villagers gathered there. *Is he trying to make money? No, that's only an excuse.*

Somehow, Javier felt that Lloyd had a bigger goal in mind. Of course, what exactly that was, he couldn't guess. But he was still certain that this behavior wasn't characteristic of Lloyd. *It's as if he's become a different person overnight.*

His manner of speech was different, his attitude and expressions, and he suddenly had new skills to show off. He designed buildings and showcased

whole new heating systems. It was puzzling.

He wondered if maybe he really was a different person. Yet, no matter how closely he watched, the man walking ahead of him step by step truly was that monster, Lloyd Frontera. *Then maybe he's been hiding this side of himself the whole time.*

That was the only explanation; the only thing that made sense of it all.

Previously he led a life of leisure as part of a baron's family, but once the household hit hard times, he's suddenly showing his true self? He really had no idea if that was the case, of course, it was too soon to make any conclusions. *For now, I'll stick to my mission.*

And, if it was possible, he'd continue keeping an eye on that jerk, Javier promised to himself, as he glared at the back of Lloyd's head.

At that moment, an unexpected message popped up in front of Lloyd.

***

Ding Dong!

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by two points.

Current RP with Javier Asrahan: -29]

[You have earned 36 RP by improving relationships with a key character.

Current RP: 36]

[Investing in RP will allow you to develop special skills.]

What's this again?

The message floated ahead of him, and Lloyd's eyes fluttered around as he read it.

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Chapter 5: Increasing Relationship Points (1)

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by two points.

Current RP with Javier Asrahan: -29]

[You have earned 36 RP by improving relationships with a key character.

Current RP: 36]

[Investing in RP will allow you to develop special skills.]

What is this now? A mid-air message floated in front of him.

Somehow, it didn't feel unfamiliar. *Come to think of it, I saw something like this when I first arrived here.* It was when Javier first woke him up. He heard a voice saying something about RP then too. *I thought it was just a silly dream.*

But that didn't seem to be the case anymore.

No matter, it was baffling. He wondered what this RP and special skills were all about.

Approval? Improve relationships with the main character?

Lloyd moved his eyes rapidly. He confirmed the message was in front of him.

It wasn't hard to understand.

My approval rating with Javier went up, and our relationship slightly improved. Therefore, I can use this RP I earned to develop my skills?

Lloyd stopped walking, and Javier turned to face him.

"Hey."

“Yes.”

“What were you thinking just now?”

“I’m not sure what you mean.”

“I bet you just judged or made some comment about me in your head, didn’t you? Something like, ‘I thought this guy totally sucked, but it turns out he’s not a complete piece of trash’.”

“I never thought that.”

“Yes, you did.”

“I did not.”

“Really? You didn’t think I was a complete piece of trash earlier?”

“Yes,” Javier said with a sincere expression.

“There is not one person who is pure trash in this world. No matter how much of a mess they are, everyone has at least a shred of human kindness somewhere deep in their hearts. That is what I believe.”

“That’s very comforting.”

To reiterate, Javier had a talent for straightforwardly and carefully making his every word be felt to your bones… no, to your very marrow. Even before you realized it.

“*Tsk*, let’s just head home.” They started walking toward the manor again.

He sent Javier to his quarters and closed his bedroom door once he was alone. He opened the message related to skills and read it in earnest.

The way to open it was simple. “Skill window.” He tried just to be sure.

[Loading the skill window.]

“Dang, it really works.”

He thought events that felt like fiction had been taking place since he came into the world of the novel. However, what was happening now seemed even more fantastic.

Lloyd looked admiringly at the skill window in front of him.

[Log of special skills that can be developed.]

[Survey skill to identify terrain and space detected.]

[Soil mechanics skill detected.]

[Hydraulics skill detected.]

[These can be combined into a “basic surveying” skill.]

[RP needed for skill development = 15]

What?!

Surveying. A survey was done before designing a structure to identify the topography and expanse of the land. As the word itself suggested, it was one of the basics of civil engineering. That was because surveying was the start of construction.

Yet, I can develop surveying as a skill?

It seemed that his existing knowledge and talent significantly impacted what skills he could develop. Lloyd confirmed this thought while looking at the continually emerging messages.

[Material mechanics skill detected. Statics skill of handling stationary objects detected.]

[Structural mechanics skill detected.]

[Water supply and sewage theory skill detected.]

[Steel structure design and concrete design skill detected.]

[Experience and skill in CAD programming detected.]

[The abilities above can be combined into a “basic design” skill.]

[RP needed for skill development = 20]

Not only was there surveying, but there was also design. These were all things he tirelessly studied in school.

Lloyd tightly squeezed his fist without realizing it. *Awesome.*

In any case, he was planning to start construction soon to relieve the baron’s debt and earn a fortune. He was even thinking of creating a large-scale construction business in the future.

What he needed most were precise surveys and designs.

But there wasn’t any equipment available here. I couldn’t even dream of a GPS surveyor, and designing was even more hopeless.

He had to draw the design for the heated flooring system by hand.

At that moment, he missed the CAD software he had conveniently used in South Korea.

However, those skills equipped him to do all of these things.

Lloyd made a bold decision. *Let’s develop basic surveying and design skills.*

He invested 15 RP for now.

The response was immediate.

[Basic surveying skill has been developed.]

[Skill Name: Basic Surveying]

[Consumes a small amount of mana. You can use your eyes to calculate the exact figures of a land’s terrain, area, and altitude. Additionally, you can get a rough insight on the properties of the soil and water that make up a topographic surface.]

[Area that can be measured at once: 330 square feet]

Is this real? Lloyd pinched himself.

He couldn’t believe he could survey 33 feet all at once with his bare eyes. He could even grasp the properties of the soil and bodies of water within range.

It almost felt like cheating.

Let’s check it out first.

He opened his window. Fortunately, his bedroom was on the second floor, and he could see all of the manor’s courtyard. He used his skill while looking around the courtyard.

“Basic surveying.”

[Surveying will begin.]

The message rang out loud. At the same time, part of his view changed into an augmented reality view.

Thirty-three feet by thirty-three feet. Countless numbers and data points appeared overlaid on the given area.

“Amazing.” It was as if he had turned on a 3D map in his head.

While he was at it, he invested 20 RP into developing basic design skills.

[Basic design skill has been developed.]

[Skill Name: Basic Design Skill]

[Consumes a small amount of mana. You can visualize your desired design drawing in the air through three-dimensional forms of dots, lines, and surfaces. Any modeling errors in the drawing will be automatically corrected.]

[Volume of structure that can be projected at once: 3,300 cubic feet]

Let's test this out. He immediately put the skill to use.

A virtual pitch-black space formed in the air before his eyes. Inside it, he could freely manipulate the 3D dots, lines, and surfaces. He could even recall the land's topography he's just now identified with the basic surveying skill!

It was like being able to limitlessly use a futuristic three-dimensional hologram version of the CAD design program.

Oh man. This is nuts. He was swooning at this point.

Is this what it feels like to become the god of architecture? Although, the area of surveying and design is certainly still a bit small. That issue will naturally resolve as I develop more skills in the future.

However, Lloyd felt slightly upset. *It would've been nice if I had a skill for heavy machinery or construction equipment.*

If he did, he could have even made his own construction equipment. But he did not have that skill. He was a civil engineer, not a mechanical engineer.

Lloyd wistfully licked his lips while looking through the skill window.

Then, his eyes suddenly focused on one spot.

What's this?

[Random Summon Game]

[Send RP to pick a summon.]

[A strong and unique summon partner will provide their unwavering loyalty along with a wide range of skills to their master.]

That was the introduction message written down.

Is this like some sort of mobile lottery game? There are all kinds of things here. I want to try it if possible. But I can't because I don't have enough RP.

[1 Turn = 50 RP]

Tsk, as if.

He had used up most of his RP while acquiring two skills just now and only had one RP point left. *I need to collect more RP.*

He already knew how to. He needed to win the favor of the main characters around him to improve his relationships with them. There actually were many ways to accomplish this, especially now.

It was at this exact time. He suddenly remembered the first part of the novel *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

It was during the time when Javier was still working at the baron's manor. Lord Frontera was severely struggling with the debt collectors who came by every day. *That might happen today too.* He called the maid and quietly asked. The maid nodded their head. "Ah, yes, young master. There were guests who came looking for the lord earlier."

As I expected. Why else would there be a guest at this time? Lloyd smiled. *Perfect timing. How great of them to come right when I need them.*

Another way to earn more RP came to his mind.

Lloyd left his bedroom and headed toward the baron's office.

***

"So… what are you going to do now!?"

As Lloyd reached the front of the office, an enraged voice leaked into the hallway. Whether it was because the old manor wasn't properly soundproofed or the uproar inside was greater than he thought, he could only tell it was the latter once he opened the door.

"Lord, how much longer are you going to delay this? Hasn't it been over five days since the promised date?"

"He's right. We won't stay still if you keep dragging this on."

There were two debt collectors there. A pudgy man with a potbelly and a bony man who had a sickly pale complexion.

The two men had their hands on their hips and their chins raised.

And Lord Frontera? He was sitting in his chair, sighing deeply. His drooping shoulders and face made him look like a guilty criminal.

Well, his feelings are understandable.

The potbellied man and the bony man who came today were vicious loan sharks. They never gave up on collecting money. They were the type of people who would try to make more money by selling off their debtor's corpses if they died.

Of course, they might meet their ends while pulling that sort of stunt while Javier slashes their throats.

That event would occur in the distant future, one year from now, after the baron's suicide.

Tsk, how did they end up borrowing money from people like them? He clicked his tongue without realizing it and took a step forward.

He spoke in a subdued voice. "No matter what anyone says, Lord Frontera is the owner of this manor. If you came as a guest, please be polite."

They must've noticed his existence only just then. The two loan sharks turned their heads toward him.

The baron lifted his head.

“Lloyd?” He spoke in a surprised voice.

Lloyd lowered his head slightly toward him.

The potbellied man tilted his head and interrupted them. “Who are you?”

“I am the eldest son of this family.”

“Eldest son?”

“Yes.”

“Aha, the eldest son with the particular manners?”

“I am a bit famous thanks to that.”

“Is that why you are so rudely interrupting our discussion like this?”

“It’s for the honor of this manor’s owner, the baron’s family.”

“That’s a problem.”

“Why so?”

“The owner of this manor will change soon.”

“Time will tell whether the owner changes or not.”

He smiled. “Show me your warrant now.”

“What…?” The potbellied man furrowed his eyebrows.

Lloyd sneered even harder at him and asked, “Don’t you have a warrant?”

“What warrant are you asking for?”

“The Royal Family and Nobility Act, Article 3, Clause 6. All nobles of the kingdom, regardless of status or rank, have appropriate rights and honors as

vassals of the king. An aristocrat may exercise their right to protect their personal interests."

"What…"

"I am saying, strictly according to the laws of the kingdom…entry into the residence of a noble family without a warrant is considered trespassing under aristocratic law."

"Are you saying we are trespassing?"

"Ah, did you finally understand?" He clapped his hands.

In reality, no one followed this law. However, it was one that clearly existed.

He suddenly remembered the delightful scene at the beginning of the novel *The Knight of Blood and Iron.*

It was immediately after the Frontera couple's suicide. A funeral was held at the baron's mansion, and the two loan sharks had come. They caused an uproar, demanding the corpses of the baron and baroness because they needed to sell them.

Right then, Javier pulled out his sword. He asserted the law and slashed the two in one stroke.

Afterward, Javier was brought before a judge but luckily didn't receive any punishment. It was because that law did indeed exist, and the two loan sharks had come without an invitation and caused a great uproar.

Of course, I can't just kill them since they aren't acting as badly right now. But it was the perfect excuse to kick them out.

"Take care then. I hope you learn some manners before your next visit."

"Do you think you'll get away with this?"

"Time will tell the answer to that as well."

The two snarling loan sharks looked ridiculous. They left the office trembling with rage.

Lloyd sent them off with a burst of mocking laughter.

That was when he finally heard Lord Frontera's urgent voice. "What… have you done?"

When he turned around, the baron's face was completely frozen.

Well, it was understandable.

After all, the least they could do was appease the spirited debt collectors, let alone provoke them and kick them out.

A bitter laugh escaped him. *Those hyena-like bastards.*

Painful memories from South Korea resurfaced in his mind. His parents became victims of insurance fraud. The debt collectors who came every day. His father faded away day by day under their constant harassment.

I won't ever be put in that position again.

The more you weakly cowered, the more you'd be pushed around. That was especially true with bastards like them. However, the baron was in a tough situation. It was much more difficult than you'd think to be confident during hard times. Realistically it was almost impossible.

"Answer my question. What have you just done?" The baron's face had crumpled somewhere along the line. He probably believed his clueless son made a huge mess of things. It was better to show instead of tell in these situations.

He took out a pouch from his arms and placed it on the baron's desk. There was a heavy jingling sound.

"Don't worry."

"What?"

“This should be more than enough to cover this month’s interest. Resolve it with this. Things will quiet down for the time being.”

“What… is this?”

It was the down payments from the heated floors he sold today. However, he did not explain it himself. There was someone else who, at least for now, was more trusted than him.

“If you’re curious, ask Sir Asrahan for the answer.”

Lloyd lowered his head to the baron and quickly left the office before he could be stopped.

Whew. He finally released the breath he was holding. He shook his head once to brush off his pounding heart. He didn’t head toward his bedroom. He went toward the training hall in the back instead.

The training hall was full of moonlight instead of people. He briefly strolled while waiting for about an hour. *The alert should come right about now.*

Just when he had that thought, the alert he was waiting for came.

Ding Dong.

[Your likeability with Arcos Frontera has increased by six points.]

[Current RP with Arcos Frontera: -14]

[You have earned 60 RP by improving relationships with main characters.]

[Current RP: 61]

Perfect. He clenched his fist.

As expected, the baron seemed to have called in Javier. He must’ve heard about Lloyd’s recent doings through Javier’s explanation.

All is going as planned.

It was less effective to speak of your own good deeds. This was even more true if the good deed came from a guy who had previously acted like nothing more than trash.

Good job, Javier

Javier likely gave a cold and objective explanation, which would’ve made the account even more believable.

Thanks to you, I have 61 RP in total.

It had paid off to wait purposefully in the empty training hall. Finally, it was time to draw his first summon partner.

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Chapter 6: Increasing Relationship Points (2)

Good job, Javier.

He felt a sense of gratitude arise from seeing the message in front of him.

Javier likely gave a cold and objective explanation of what happened.

Javier was the main character of the novel *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* He was a cold-blooded and stubborn guy. He wasn't shaken up by any situation. He strived to be objective about everything. He probably tried to show up earlier as well.

There was no doubt he calmly informed the baron of what Lloyd had done and how he had behaved all this time.

It's a relief that the baron didn't negatively judge me.

It was actually a slight gamble.

He used to be a son who did nothing but cause trouble every day. But he suddenly revealed knowledge not known before. He made a heated flooring system that didn't even exist here. As if that wasn't enough, he took things further by making money by setting up construction contracts with the villagers.

It would be justifiable for the baron to be suspicious of the situation.

But he wasn't.

Of course, he probably thought it was strange. However, he seemed to be happy more than anything.

That's just the heart of a parent.

Was there any parent who didn't first feel overwhelming happiness in a situation where their kid changed for the better?

On the one hand, it did feel unsettling to take advantage of that sincerity, but on the other hand, he didn’t have another choice right now.

For now, let’s just push forward and see what happens.

It was practicality over morality in the present. This was the time to seek profit through practical means.

If not, he would repeat his life in South Korea, forever struggling with poverty.

With that determination, Lloyd looked around at his surroundings again. Thankfully, he didn’t sense another person’s presence in the moonlit training hall.

He took a deep breath and opened the window.

His eyes followed one spot among the sea of information flooding before him.

[Random Summon Game]

[Send RP to pick a summon.]

[A strong and unique summon partner will provide their unwavering loyalty along with a wide range of skills to their master.]

[1 Turn = 50 RP]

[Current RP: 61]

[Would you like to start the summon game?]

[YES / NO]

He chose ‘Yes’ of course and nodded his head.

[The random summon game is starting.]

50 RP were expended with the introduction message.

At the same time, there was something emerging five steps ahead of him.

Fwoosh!

The ground was engraved with a pale light that formed a complex figure. The magic circle gave off mystical energy.

Is it coming out?

He frequently saw this scene in mobile games, but it was a little different seeing it in real life. No, it was very different. It couldn't be compared to mediocre 3D visual effects.

He radiated with anticipation for what would come out of the magic circle. It was heart-pounding to just watch.

Then, something came out at last. *Bzzzt!* Something surged from the ground with a strong shock wave.

It flew over in his direction, right into his arms.

"Ppodong!"

Soft and fluffy. Furry. Plump bottom. Short arms and legs. A petite figure that was smaller than half his fist.

This was a…

"Hamster?"

"Ppodong!"

"Why did a hamster come out of here?"

"Ppodong! Ppodong!"

"One came out because it's you?"

“Ppodong!”

The hamster nodded his head like it was obvious.

Lloyd set down the hamster, feeling bewildered.

This is a summon partner?

He had used a whopping 50 RP to play the game.

But in the end, what had come out was one mere hamster that couldn’t be seen as anything other than a pet.

However, Lloyd didn’t panic and calmed himself down instead.

I was told that summon partners had a wide variety of skills. First thing, this fella understands my words and responds to me. It must mean he’s not an ordinary hamster starting with this.

It wasn’t only that. Somehow, he could also understand Ppodong’s responses. They could communicate.

He lifted the hamster onto his palm, looked at him, and said, “Hey.”

“Ppodong?”

“Do you have any special abilities?

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“You said you’re a summon partner.”

“Ppodong!”

“How about showing some proof that you are one?”

“Ppo-do-dong? Ppodong!”

The hamster stuffed both hands into his mouth and pulled something out of his cheek. It was a small envelope and a wrinkled piece of paper the size of a business card.

“Ppodong?” “Ppo-do-dong!”

“You’re giving me this?”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“Read the paper?”

“Ppodong!”

He smoothed out the piece of paper and saw tiny written words that resembled black sesame. Thankfully, the moonlight was bright so he could manage to read the content.

[Ppodong User Manual

Ppodong is an adorable hamster. Please give him lots of love.

Ppodong will give his utmost loyalty to you, his master. A summon partner is not only your companion animal but also your family, so please don’t neglect them.

Ppodong can change his size by eating one of the enclosed sunflower seeds.]

[Red Sunflower Seed: Ppodong grows to gigantic proportions. Effective for maximum 12 hours.]

[Blue Sunflower Seed: Ppodong shrinks back to a smaller size. Feed this to Ppodong before the 12-hour period ends. Otherwise, he will automatically shrink back once the time limit passes and be too exhausted to grow again for 24 hours.]

[One set of the two colors of sunflower seeds is 1 RP.]

[Ppodong can use a wide range of skills while he is gigantic.]

[Ppodong’s Skill Log]

[Digging (Lv. 1)]

[Packing Dirt (Lv. 1)]

[Cheer Pockets (Lv. 1)]

Hmm. Digging and packing dirt. Could he be used as a forklift?

After Llyod read the user manual, he opened the enclosed envelope that came with it. As expected, there were sunflower seeds inside. *There are ten each of red and blue sunflower seeds.*

Lloyd stared at the hamster, no, Ppodong. “Hey, you.”

“Ppodong?”

“So, you get bigger if you eat this?”

“Ppodong!”

“How big?”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“Very big?”

“Ppodong!”

How much bigger can he get? He’s naturally so small.

Size was a relative concept. He wondered how much bigger it could possibly grow.

He’ll have plenty of uses if he even manages to become human-sized.

He never had a pet hamster before. He only heard somewhere that hamsters were good at digging furrows. That was why he anticipated human-sized Ppodong to be able to do the work of several people.

“Let’s first check it out.”

“Ppodong?”

“Get down first.”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

He set Ppodong on the ground and held out a red sunflower seed.

“Do you want to try this?”

“Ppodong?”

“Doesn’t it smell good?”

“Ppo-do-dong? Ppodong?”

“Here, it’ll taste good.”

“Ppodong!”

The hamster sniffed his nose and quickly snatched the sunflower seed. He put it in his mouth and chewed.

Lloyd took a few steps back.

How big will he get? He studied him with equal parts excitement and worry.

And then, the moment Ppodong swallowed the sunflower seed he was munching on…

BOOM!

He grew to over 30 feet tall.

Amazing. Wow. Lloyd looked up in disbelief. Ppodong's face was very far up now that he transformed into a giant hamster.

If I hadn't moved back enough, I could've crashed into him and gone flying like a bouncy ball.

The growth happened in an instant, like popcorn popping or an airbag in a car crash. Ppodong enlarged at an extreme rate.

If he hadn't made enough space between them? He would've crashed against the growing hamster and went flying as if he was in a road accident.

I'll be careful from now on. He made up his mind and looked up at Ppodong.

No matter, he needed to test Ppodong's skills right now.

"Hey, can you hear me?"

"Ppodong?" The hamster looked down at him with his gigantic head.

Thankfully, his eyes still looked friendly. He was no longer worried about getting eaten.

"Do you want to try digging?"

"Ppo-do-dong?"

"Can you make a straight two-meter-deep furrow from here to there?"

"Ppodong?" "Ppo-do-dong!" Ppodong nodded his head.

He swayed his giant chubby butt while moving to the indicated destination. Then he started moving his two short front paws at lightning speed.

"Ppo-do-do-dong!"

Swish! Swish! Swish! It was a soil storm; mounds of dirt explosively flew up into the air.

Ppodong’s chubby body ruthlessly moved forward.

After just three minutes, a gigantic two-meter deep and twenty-meter-long furrow was completed in the training hall.

“Amazing.” It was beyond his wildest dreams and above any of his expectations.

However, Llyod quickly snapped out of his admiring trance. There wasn’t time to be in awe.

I don’t know who might catch this sight after all. He decided to finish the test as swiftly and efficiently as possible.

With that thought in mind, Lloyd spoke to Ppodong. “Good job. Next is packing the dirt.”

“Ppodong?”

“Try filling in the furrow you just made as flatly as possible.”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“Can you do it?”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong moved at once. He got into position in front of the recently made furrow. Then he shook his fluffy butt and spread his paws. Finally, he darted rapidly from side to side with gusto.

“Ppo-do-do-dong!”

“Swoosh! Swoosh! Swoosh!”

If the earlier digging was like a soil storm, his current movements were like a vacuum cleaner.

Ppodong’s plump butt was his center of gravity. His hefty behind grounded him as he quickly moved from side to side.

He gathered the messily scattered mounds of dirt he dug earlier and pushed them into the furrow.

The hamster ruthlessly advanced, and the furrow filled in more each time he moved forward. But that wasn’t the end.

“Ppo-do-dong!”

Once Ppodong finished filling in the furrow, he laid his body down and started rolling along the area. Once forward, once back. That was enough.

He used the dense wall of fat on his side to compress the ground like a steamroller.

Thanks to that, the bumpy surface became completely flat after he rolled back and forth over it. There wasn’t a single trace left of the furrow.

Good. Very good. The more he looked, the more he was satisfied.

Lloyd felt Ppodong was worth the 50 RP he invested. *What a relief. I had overworked myself to collect the RP.*

He had purposefully visited the baron while he was quarreling with the debt collectors and went a bit overboard to improve his appeal. This was all so he could increase his approval with the baron.

It was worth the risk of being suspected. Now, I should test out the final skill.

Lloyd looked up at Ppodong. The hamster was proudly looking at the furrow he filled into perfection.

“Hey, Ppodong?”

“Ppodong?”

“You have cheek pockets, right?”

“Ppodong!”

“Can you hold stuff in there?”

“Ppo-do-dong? Ppodong!”

“It’s possible? How much?”

“Ppodong!” The hamster pointed his paw across the yard to a rock that was about six feet in diameter.

Lloyd knit his eyebrows. *No way.*

However, it was real.

Before he could say anything, Ppodong had already started moving and put the rock in one of his cheeks.

“Ppu-du-dung!”

“Amazing…”

“Ppuduuung! Ppudung!” “Are you okay?”

“Ppudung! Ppu-du-dung!” He proudly nodded his head.

Every time he nodded, the cheek stuffed with rocks swayed ominously.

I could even use him as a weapon. He’s built like a tank.

Lloyd knew Ppodong was thirty-three feet tall, but he felt like he had met a dinosaur, seeing him in real life. Even the elephants he had seen at the zoo seemed like puppies compared to Ppodong.

“Now, put the rock back in its place.”

“Ppodong?” *Ptooey!*

“Good job. Do you want to eat this now?

“Ppodong!”

He put the blue sunflower seed in the hamster’s mouth. Ppodong instantly turned small once he swallowed the sunflower seed. *Poof.*

He took the shrunken hamster in his arms. Ppodong must’ve been tired as he pushed into Lloyd’s inside pocket.

Lloyd felt his small weight and warmth.

It was a success. This is amazing.

He went over what he saw of Ppodong today. The results had far surpassed his expectations.

He dug a sixty-five-foot-long and six-foot-deep furrow in only three minutes and perfectly filled it back in. Furthermore, he was even able to hold a rock weighing several tons in one cheek.

A high-power forklift, a perfect steamroller, and even a dump truck. He had all three functions in one body. It felt like getting the Swiss army knife of heavy machinery.

With these capabilities, he wouldn’t hesitate to spend RP on the sunflower seeds needed for transformation.

On top of everything, he’s incredibly portable.

Before he knew it, Ppodong had fallen fast asleep in his inner pocket.

He probably had to hide him for the time being.

I’ll have to carry around a summoning book. He needed at least this much of an excuse to prepare for when Ppodong would be seen by others. That way, it wouldn’t look suspicious if the troublemaker of the baron’s family suddenly summoned a giant hamster. If anything, people would chant, “Our young master is the best!”

With that, he escaped the training hall with Ppodong in his arms.

As he returned to his bedroom, he thought of what to do next.

I finally have decent construction equipment. Now, it's time to seriously start building.

He already had a successful sale with the heated flooring systems earlier today. It was wise to strike while the iron was hot. He planned to follow the momentum and start his construction business.

To do that, I need a construction team with engineers and seasoned laborers, who will dependably work on-site, and a capable individual to lead them.

Of course, he had thought about how to organize the field team before.

Flicker. The fireplace in the bedroom burned all night.

Lloyd picked up a sheet of paper and a pen.

He refreshed his memories and began making a list of all the main characters early on in the novel *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

That was the memorable start of how Baron Frontera's ordinary knights and guards would be transformed into a full-scale construction army.

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Chapter 7: Overhaul (1)

Lord Frontera's barony was an ordinary rural estate in the corner of the Lorasian continent. His military forces were abysmally small. Not only were they small, but they were pathetic. There were five knights and one hundred soldiers. Even then, they were more like a vigilante gang. That was how the novel *The Knight of Blood and Iron* described the condition of Lord Frontera's dominion.

It was a sunny morning. The perfect weather to start construction. Under the sun, Lloyd spoke to the eighty men gathered by the river. "…from today on, you will be reborn as elite soldiers on the field. If you work hard to dig up and move everything here, that is." He pointed to the riverside. There was red clay where he pointed. A tremendous amount of it at that.

The red clay had been buried deep in the ground. *However, I was able to dig it up thanks to Ppodong.*

He had secretly come here early in the morning and created the mound of red clay in just thirty minutes by transforming Ppodong. Afterward, he brought eighty soldiers of the estate here at sunrise, so they could transport the red clay to the construction site.

He looked around at his troops. "You're probably wondering what's going on and why you're being tasked with this kind of labor. That's just how the military is. What's the highlight of the military? It's work."

The Korean army was the same. What about the battle training meant for protecting the nation? That was important, too, but real life was a little different. *From trench to drainage construction, I was building one thing today and another the next. I was given project after project, and my time in the military went by before I knew it.*

He felt like he became the staff sergeant's personal summoner. That was why he wanted to give this estate's soldiers the same experience. It wasn't just to torture them. *It's physical exercise disguised as menial labor.*

The red clay was heavy. If you carried around a sack full of red clay? It not only trained the lower body but the abdominal core, shoulders, back, and forearms. The boost in endurance was also a bonus. *Labor builds muscle.*

With that thought, Lloyd spoke out. “Anyway, we are about to break ground on our estate’s renaissance. I’m talking about the heated flooring construction for the people. To do that, I need all of you to move that clay to the construction site.”

“Yes, young master…” A few soldiers grudgingly replied.

Lloyd smiled. “Good. Then let’s start by stretching.”

“Huh?”

“Do you want to get hurt while working? It’ll be your loss if you hurt your back and knees from pushing your stiff body to carry the heavy supplies. Understand? So, you should warm up your body.”

“Copy my moves. One, two.”

“O-one… two…”

“You’re too quiet. Move properly. One, two!”

“O-one, two!”

Lloyd slowly warmed up his body in front of the soldiers. The soldiers seemed dazed at first. But they started moving faster once Lloyd started making a face at them. The infamous master troublemaker. The notoriety he had amassed this entire time paid off. *There’s no point in training if you don’t warm up and end up getting hurt while working.* Stretching was more important than you’d expect on a construction site.

The ground could be bumpy, or there could be dangerous objects littered everywhere. Most construction sites were in similarly poor conditions. And if you tried lifting heavy objects without properly warming up? Inevitably, the likelihood of an accident happening went up. Lloyd intended to avoid such accidents at any cost.

I don’t have money to give for treatment. I’ll save that money by taking precautions. That’s why I’m shouting these stupid-sounding chants with all my heart.

He gathered the soldiers in a circle after he finished stretching. He raised his hand. “Copy my moves. Raise your hand.” One by one, the soldiers raised their hands while glancing at each other. Lloyd shouted out a chant. “I will wear a safety helmet!” *Tap tap!* He hit the helmet he was wearing with his palm.

The soldiers shouted the chant while copying his movement. “I-I will wear… a safety helmet!”

“Good job. I will wear safety gloves!”

“I will wear safety gloves!”

“I will wear safety shoes!”

“I really will!”

At first glance, it was a childish chant and inspection process that better fit a kindergarten classroom. Lloyd thought the same when he was a part-time construction worker in Korea during morning assemblies.

But now that he looked back? He suspected this inspection process was what allowed him to finish his part-time job safely. That thought sometimes crossed his mind. That’s why he didn’t forget to pound safety protocols into the soldiers’ heads one last time after finishing the inspection.

“Don’t forget about the safety precautions. If you think you’ll forget, then take a look at this.” He picked up the sign he made in advance and stuck it in the ground.

The sign had these words written precisely on it:

Safety First!

Workers! Always follow safety precautions on site. If you rush in without a helmet, you may end up closing the barn door after the horse has bolted.

For some reason, if you act recklessly like you're leading a warfare maneuver, you will end up like a victim on the battlefield. You're too lazy to wear safety shoes? I hereby see your big toe has finished preparing its launch to separate into three sections like a rocket. Does this all seem like a lie? If so, ignore all my warnings and die from dioxin poisoning.

ps. You think it can't happen to you, right? Ha!

The soldiers went silent. They all carefully adjusted their safety equipment.

"Good. Let's start if you're ready. Group one, fill the sacks with red clay. Group two, carry the sacks. Go!"

"Yes!"

The floor heating project started on an intense note.

Perhaps due to their mental training, the soldiers were moving fast. He felt pleased watching them.

As expected, they're relatively obedient since they're the estate's soldiers. Persuading the baron was a good decision.

Suddenly, he thought of the incident that happened two hours ago that morning.

***

"So, you want to mobilize the soldiers?" His questioning voice held confusion. Along with confusion, it also held suspicion and disbelief.

Lloyd calmly continued eating breakfast and replied, "Yes."

"For what?"

“There is work I need to assign them”

“What kind of work are you assigning for you to mobilize eighty soldiers.”

“It’s construction work.”

“Construction?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd swallowed his bread and wiped his hands with a napkin. Then he pulled out the document he had prepared. He pushed it over to the baron.

“This is a business plan.”

“What do you mean by a business plan?”

“Please look at it carefully first.”

It was all because he got Ppodong last night. He finally had the confidence to start a full-scale construction business. Thus, he spent all night writing a business plan. *The baron’s cooperation is necessary for this business.*

Regardless of anything, it was a business within the fiefdom. As such, he needed permission from the baron who was the lord of the manor. It was true from an economic perspective as well. *It costs money to separately hire laborers.* Personal expenses or daily wages. These were necessary expenses for all construction sites.

But if the baron mobilized his personal soldiers for construction? He could work them for free, since these soldiers were hired by the baron and already on salary.

“Therefore, you should be able to save a fair amount of money.”

“What if there is discontent amongst the soldiers?”

“You can appease them by giving extra cash to them under the guise of providing a bonus.”

“Hmm, but a heated flooring construction business?”

“I was under the impression you listened to Javier’s explanation last night.”

“Yes. Yes, I did. I heard about the strange new heating method that warms the rocks laid on the ground. But why?”

“Are you questioning my intentions?”

“Yes.”

The baron’s eyes looking his way were full of suspicion. But thankfully, they weren’t frigid like before. *It’s probably because I chased out the debt collectors and presented a money sack to him yesterday.* The baron was able to take care of this month’s interest thanks to that. No small wonder his eyes softened toward Lloyd.

Lloyd spoke. “I wanted to collect money through the villagers.”

“Money?”

“Yes. Money for the debt.”

“I thought of gathering money through special taxes at first.” “But with that…”

“The backlash would be severe.”

“Yes. That was why. I thought of the most legitimate method that would have the least backlash. “

“So, you’re saying a construction business for the so-called heated flooring is what you came up with?”

“Yes. I would make money, and the villagers would be able to have a warm winter in exchange for paying a fair price. It’s a win-win situation.

“By the way, where did you…” The baron’s particularly suspicious gaze turned his way. “Where did you learn this?”

“Are you talking about the heated floors?”

“Yes. It’s my first time ever seeing something like this. So where did you learn about it?”

“I thought of it a while ago.”

“Thought of it?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded his head. He needed to be brazen in these kinds of moments. He continued talking. “It’s just something I vaguely thought about over the years. A heated stone doesn’t cool easily. So, I wondered what would happen if I laid flat stones on top of a floor and then blew hot smoke underneath them. I got the opportunity to actually build it this time, and it turned out better than I thought. It was warmer than expected too.

“Do you mean the heated floors you built the pub owner?”

“Yes.”

“That’s how you came up with the idea to make it into a business?”

“Yes.” He nodded his head like it was obvious. Truthfully, he did have absolute confidence. But there was still a stubborn trace of suspicion in the baron’s face.

“Yes. The plan is good. This is a well-made plan that’s worthy of praise. I almost can’t believe you’re so talented. But…” The question the baron threw at him was riddled with doubt. “Can I trust your intentions?”

“What?”

“I’m asking if I can trust you.”

“I’m not sure what you mean…”

“You couldn’t have forgotten what happened two years ago, right?”

Two years ago… That part didn’t appear in the novel. It was not in *The Knight of Blood and Iron*. It didn’t seem like a good idea to give a sloppy response right now. Lloyd waited in silence. Luckily, the baron spoke up first.

“You were the same then. Although, you obviously didn’t have a robust business plan like now. I clearly remember what you told me. You said ‘I will really pull myself together and study hard this time. So please believe me and make an investment.’”

“I was happy. I thought you would finally mend your ways. That was why I readily gave you the money that came from selling the villa for the academy tuition. But…”

“You completely wasted every single cent with the scoundrels you used to go along with! All the while, you shamelessly played around with women and threw grimy parties in a drunken stupor.”

…ah, seriously. Lloyd, you bastard. He swallowed the curse words that threatened to come out of his mouth. *He’s a troublemaker, alright. I never dreamed he would’ve done something like that.* He thought it was no wonder the baron had such a lukewarm reaction to a perfect business plan. It was a given he couldn’t be trusted after doing something like that. *Ugh, you’re a piece of trash, original Lloyd.*

His body’s old owner was massively trolling him. He wondered how he would bounce back from this. His brain worked at the speed of light. And at last, he found a clue to the problem. It was thanks to the memories of his past that suddenly came to him.

Come to think of it, I caused similar trouble before, even though it was on a much smaller scale.

It was probably when he was in middle school. He stole the money his mom gave him for his school tutoring at the time. He remembered using it to go to the arcade with his friends every night.

From first-person shooting games to car racing, and even battle arena games… It was a fun time.

However, he ultimately got caught by his mom. She was extremely angry. He had to go on his knees and beg for forgiveness. After a while, he finally earned his mom's forgiveness, but only after making an unbreakable promise.

Tsk, that's the only option I have right now.

Lloyd lifted his head once he found a solution and faced the baron. He spoke to the baron just like when he promised his mom, he would never go to the arcade again. "I will quit drinking."

"What…?"

"Just as I said, I will completely quit drinking if you give me your trust in this."

The baron's look became strange. It seemed to ask if he was serious or if he was up to something.

Lloyd never replied. He just didn't avoid the baron's stare. He stayed silent as if he was answering yes with his tranquil eyes. He didn't know how long they stayed like that.

The baron finally let out a sigh. "Is that true?"

"Yes."

He was a lightweight anyway and didn't really like alcohol either. There was also nothing he particularly missed about getting drunk. So, if he gained even a little bit of the baron's trust by giving up alcohol, that would truly be a huge win.

And at last…

"Alright, I understand." The baron nodded his head. He returned the business plan to Lloyd.

“I will trust you just this once since you went so far as to promise that. I will report to my executive officer that you are allowed to freely utilize the estate’s soldiers in order to advance this business plan.”

“Thank you.”

“This will be the last time I trust you like this. Please don’t disappoint me.”

The baron’s expression somehow felt gentler than earlier and even seemed to pity him a little bit.

The image of his mom during the arcade incident suddenly flashed in his head, and he briefly felt a strange emotion.

Lloyd hurriedly finished his meal and left the table.

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I got through that step, but there are many more obstacles I have to overcome as expected. With that thought, his lips curved to a bitter smile. It was because of the knight who had approached him while he was briefly lost in thought.

“As you know, I’m an honorable knight. I can’t accept an order to oversee these dirt sacks getting carried even if it comes from the young master.”

The soldier looking his way had repulsive facial features.

Of course, Lloyd knew his name.

Sir Ulrich.

The man he personally chose to lead the soldiers on site today. He was one of the five knights of the Frontera barony. Out of them all, he was the least skilled.

Even in his position, he was the first to betray the crumbling barony. *He stole the baron’s favorite horse and ran away.* That wasn’t all. He even spat

on Llyod’s face during their encounter while he was running away. *That’s why I entrusted you with supervising the site.*

He called him on purpose. He entrusted him to lead the soldiers. He was looking forward to seeing him resist like this. And the bastard didn’t fail to give him the reaction he was waiting for.

Lloyd wordlessly grabbed his shovel. Then he brightly smiled at Sir Ulrich. “Oh, so you will defy my order?”

“I am not defying it. I am asking you to respect my honor as a knight… Ugh!”

Slam!

The moment Sir Ulrich tried to talk back, the head of the shovel Lloyd wielded violently hit him in the face.

There’s definitely a need to revamp the estate at once.

Lloyd’s eyes glinted coldly as Sir Ulrich’s back teeth scattered in the air.

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Chapter 8: Overhaul (2)

Slam!

"…Ugh!" Sir Ulrich yelled without realizing it. The world spun. It felt like his cheek had disappeared. Something burst out of his gaping mouth. It flew and scattered in the air. It was only then that Sir Ulrich could vaguely make out what was flying into the distance.

Teeth? Three white molars were separately spinning through the air. The surrounding droplets of spit and blood had intertwined, tracing out a complex line of trajectory.

This is… interesting.

He felt strangely dazed like time had slowed down around him. Within his view, there were teeth and blood flying in the air. He had never seen anything like this in his twenty-six years of living. It was funny, but it made him dizzy.

…Uh, ugh.

His legs lost their strength. He was bent over at the waist. The ground came closer. Against his wishes, his head hit the ground with a hard thud. He was forced to kiss the ground as his lips smooshed down. Blood seeped out of his mouth again.

That was when Sir Ulrich's senses finally returned to normal. Heavy pain from his busted lip, knocked-out molars, and broken cheekbone came with it.

"…Aargh!?" It hurt. It really hurt. It hurt way too much! "What! C-cough!" He tightly held one side of his face. The pain and shock made it impossible to think. He tried to understand the situation.

How did I get hit? An accident? If not, an attack? By whom? He frantically racked his confused brain. However, his furious worrying was no good. The

answer was offered far too easily. Along with the shovel coming down toward him.

“What, what!?”

Bam!

“…Urk!” The shovel came straight down and landed on his solar plexus.

He couldn’t breathe. His waist was bent like a shrimp. He looked up to see who dared to attack him. Sir Ulrich’s eyes soon widened. “Young…? Ugh!”

Bang!

The shovel hit his face again.

His head rolled sharply over as his face was further battered.

But Sir Ulrich couldn’t give a proper response. He had already received too many blows, one after another, in his defenseless state.

H-how come? Why?

He couldn’t understand. He couldn’t respond. He couldn’t even dream of standing up. The shovel Lloyd wielded was too deadly for him to make any hasty attempts.

Faced with this ruthless violence, Sir Ulrich did nothing but groan and wrap his arms around his face and head.

Pow, bam! Slam! Whack!

“Gah! Ahh!” Sir Ulrich’s face crumpled in fear. An odd determination was embedded in his mind, which was howling in pain.

I-I’ll really die at this rate! It was true.

The glimpse of Lloyd he could see ahead of him, through the crack between his arms wrapped around his face, said it all. The troublesome young

master’s face was proving it. His eyes were too calm while swinging the shovel.

Of course. I need to stay calm to push down someone stronger than me.

Bam!

Lloyd swung his shovel relentlessly. All the while, he thought about how Sir Ulrich would get up if he was even given the slightest chance to catch his breath. If that happened, then his plan would go awry.

After all, I did to successfully launch this attack, do you think I’ll let go of this chance? Me? The first rule for successfully initiating an attack was to ambush Sir Ulrich without ever giving him a chance to react. Thanks to that, he had complete control over the situation.

Even if he’s a knight, he can’t help but collapse if he receives this kind of assault without warning. This was especially true if you were a low-class swordsman who could just barely conjure a manaheart. Like in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* A few of the baron’s knights he read about in the novel came to mind. Sir Ulrich was the most incompetent knight of them all.

He thought poorly of Lloyd, even with that status. He pretty much looked down on him.

That’s why I called you today to make an example out of you. It’ll be problematic if more people try to sabotage everything I do. At least in the fiefdom, that is. A person’s determination was important.

If you gave in during a conflict? If excessive generosity became a habit? Afterward, sacrifice and kindness would become an expectation. You were reduced to a pushover.

He had very painfully learned this truth in South Korea. *Especially on construction sites. A few of the old men there had awful personalities.* The so-called mentors. There were also many warmhearted people…

However, his luck was bad. An ill-tempered mentor became his co-worker. He had to suffer all day. His mentor nitpicked over nothing and usually cursed at him the entire time he was working. He endured it at first. It felt wrong to fight back. He just laughed and tried to be the good guy.

But that wasn't the right answer.

One day the man, his so-called mentor, insulted his parents. He had made a derogatory joke about Lloyd's family.

How did he respond that day?

I did this.

Swack! The shovel Lloyd wielded struck Sir Ulrich's shin this time.

"Ackkk!"

Sir Ulrich, who was just then struggling to stand up, clutched his shin and drew back.

However, Lloyd's face didn't change. *It only gets easier in the future after I flip out on them once.*

It was true then too. He lost control of himself the moment he heard his family being insulted. Immediately, he bashed his mentor with the shovel he was holding.

Not surprisingly, the site turned into chaos. But afterward?

Things got easier. No one readily bothered him as they did before. In a way, it was an opportunity that made him realize one truth about life.

That's why I called you to the site. Out of all the soldiers of this fiefdom, you're the weakest one. You were just barely able to create a manaheart recently. I thought an attack like this would be enough to crush you.

Lloyd based the plan on events in the novel. He predicted that Sir Ulrich would fight back or act arrogantly toward him at least once. And his

prediction was right on the mark. His punishment would serve as a warning to others. He became an example.

Pow! Bang! Slam! Lloyd didn't stop his shovel.

A scream finally burst out of Sir Ulrich's mouth. "Agh! Aghh! Y-young master! Why!"

"Why else? It's because of your lack of loyalty."

Bam!

Every time he swung the shovel, Lloyd's words were more ice cold.

"Now, try repeating what you said earlier."

"Wait… Agh!"

Bam!

"You're an honorable knight? You can't accept an order to oversee bags of dirt being carried?"

"But…"

Bam!

"Argh!"

"But nothing. Should I set the record straight? Does it look like I gathered all the soldiers without notice for personal reasons? Hm?"

Bash!

"Aaargh!"

"Do you see what is written here? This is an order to mobilize soldiers. It's an official document that was approved by my father the baron and issued by the magistrate. So…"

Wham!

“It means you dared to betray your honor as a knight and refused a legitimate order from the lawful lord of this estate to whom you pledged an oath of loyalty. In other words…”

Thwack!

“One: you disobeyed the lord’s orders.”

Thwack!

“Two: you dishonored the lord and failed your duty as a knight.”

Whack!

“Three: you have thrown away your own rights and honor.”

Baang!

Swung fully like a golf club hitting a tee shot, the shovel flew up. The flat side of the shovel slammed up under Sir Ulrich’s chin. That was the end.

Spray!

The blood droplets from the violently beaten Sir Ulrich were flying into the air along with the motion of his head. Sir Ulrich crumpled like a puppet without its strings. He passed out.

“Ha!” Lloyd caught his labored breath. He felt like his lungs would burst from the first intense exercise he had done in a while. But it was worth it.

I must get rid of everyone in my way somehow.

The Knight of Blood and Iron. The Frontera barony had been introduced to in the very scene was a mess. This was proven by the fact that Sir Ulrich, a man who had no loyalty or talent, was made a knight.

A guy like that needs to be nipped in the bud as soon as possible. Afterward, I need to fill in his empty spot with someone promising. That's the only way this barony will have a future.

This fiefdom would be his main source of income for the rest of his life. If he wanted to exploit and grow this place long-term, he needed to bring in more talent.

He wiped the sweat dripping down his forehead with his arm and looked around. "What are you looking at? Is there a show going on?"

The soldiers, who had stopped working to watch, flinched and turned their heads.

Lloyd gestured to a soldier near him. "You here, and the two there. Come over here."

"Yes, yes…!" The three soldiers rushed over at full speed.

Lloyd pointed his chin toward the sprawled-out Sir Ulrich. "Put him away. And bring Sir Bayern from the mansion."

"Yes!"

They had just plainly seen what happened to the soldier who disobeyed Lloyd. As soon as he gave the order, the three soldiers moved at lightning speed. The three carried Sir Ulrich, who had swollen up like a balloon and collapsed. They hurriedly walked back to the mansion.

***

"I heard you called for me, Master Lloyd."

A knight with a sturdy figure and rugged face arrived at the site. It was Sir Bayern, who he had ordered the soldiers to bring earlier. Lloyd put on a satisfied smile as soon as he saw Sir Bayern. *He looks better than what I imagined from reading the novel.*

Sir Bayern was one of the five knights of the Frontera barony. Like Javier, he didn't betray his lord, even at the very end. His loyalty was verified by the novel. *This is the kind of person I should invest in. If the novel is correct, his skills are just ordinary, but I need to prioritize people I can trust.*

Sir Bayern was an honest and faithful man. That's why Lloyd's goal was to entrust Sir Bayern with the construction team. *Well, I created this situation to begin with.*

He called out Sir Ulrich — who would cause harm in the future — and put a stop to his protests for his troops to see. The punishment would serve as a warning to others.

Then he called for Sir Bayern, who he had originally planned to entrust with this position.

That was how he intended to get rid of everyone he needed to, by setting the right mood onsite and appointing Sir Bayern to serve as a positive example.

Lloyd addressed Sir Bayern. "Yes, I was looking for you. I am thinking of entrusting you with overseeing the site today. How do you feel about that?"

"I will do anything you ask."

"Good. It actually isn't much. The soldiers are collecting the red clay here and moving it to the construction site. Supervise the soldiers to make sure they aren't goofing off too much during the job. Obviously, give them sufficient breaks from time to time. It'll be problematic if they pass out from overworking."

"Understood."

He didn't make a single complaint.

Sir Bayern most likely heard of what happened. But he didn't show any signs of it.

That made him seem even more trustworthy. Thus, Lloyd entrusted the clay collection site to Sir Bayern and headed elsewhere. He went to the heated flooring construction site. There were carpenters, blacksmiths, masons, plasterers, and other workers waiting for him. Of course, there wasn't anything close to admiration in the eyes of the artisans' looking at him.

They were worried about why this scumbag troublemaker called for them. They were disgusted by him, and they wanted to avoid getting involved with him as much as circumstance permitted. Their eyes seemed to be filled only with those sorts of feelings.

Lloyd didn't mind any of the looks from these craftspeople. He calmly walked in front of them. "Starting now, I will instruct you about the design concept and construction methods for the heated floors. Listen carefully."

"What…?" The artisans tilted their heads. In their eyes, Lloyd was a troublesome young master who never worked a day in his life. Despite them being old hands at construction, he was trying to teach them something new. It was like trying to teach a fish how to swim or blow fumes up a dragon's snout. Scornful emotions rose in them. But that didn't last long.

"Let's look at this first. Attention everyone."

Swoosh!

Lloyd spread the construction blueprint for the floors in front of them. It was an intricate blueprint done with great design skills. The rural artisans, who constructed buildings with only rough estimates, had never seen such a thing before. Following that, Lloyd's brilliant and professional explanation flowed with the rhythm of a steady drumbeat.

The artisans' expressions started to change a little upon hearing it.

***

Half of the day passed. As expected, Sir Bayern did not disappoint him. Thanks to his careful oversight, the soldiers carried the clay to the

construction site without any problems. The physical training they got in the process was a bonus. All the while, Lloyd had been busy.

He spent the entire day training the artisans at the work site. While wearing a work belt, he sweated profusely while putting down the flat stones and taught them how to construct the heated flooring system. *This is the process that allowed for a successful first day of construction…*

The sun started setting before he knew it. Now that he had successfully completed the official first day of construction, Lloyd inspected the site as it was wrapped up. *Luckily, the craftsmen are learning faster than I expected. It'll get easier in the future.*

Nonetheless, they were skilled artisans at the end of the day. The experience they accumulated in the field was not just for show. They showed strong interest in these construction methods that were brand new to them. They understood the fundamentals only after learning about the concept behind the design. It seemed that he could completely entrust them with the construction if he guided them for just a little longer.

Then we would finally have a crew in place. The artisans can do the skilled work, the soldiers can do the menial work that requires manpower, and Sir Bayern can supervise the whole operation. This means I can concentrate on other things, since I won't need to stay onsite every day for the project to move forward.

That was why he assembled a professional construction team from the start. A business needed to run on its own. That was how to make money while making time to invest in other matters.

Now that he had achieved that goal, it was time to move on to the next phase. *I'm not done overhauling this estate yet.*

Sir Ulrich was only the start. There were still thick rotten roots he needed to cut out. *It's about time I get a certain message.* It was around the time Lloyd had expected.

“Young master Lloyd? I came because I have something to tell you regarding Sir Ulrich.” An arrogant yet haggard voice came from behind him. Javier? It wasn’t him.

You came as expected Sir Neumann.

The senior knight of the Frontera barony, Sir Neumann, had finally arrived. A traitor who contributed the most to the downfall of the barony in the book *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

Facing Sir Neumann, Lloyd smiled like a fisherman who had just netted a big fat catfish.

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Chapter 9: Overhaul (3)

Sir Neumann, senior knight of the Frontera barony. His swordsmanship was not the best. He was just good enough to be treated as a capable knight in this rural fiefdom.

However, he was much more interested in advancing his social status than his swordsmanship. He valued money over loyalty to the lord of the manor. A rapid rise in status over knightly honor. He would do anything to reach his goals.

No, he did achieve those goals… by selling the Frontera's inside information to a swindler.

Lloyd remembered the start of the novel *The Knight of Blood and Iron*. The fall of the barony, which was the first ordeal suffered by the main character Javier. Sir Neumann was behind it.

He sold information about the barony to a crook. The scam artist approached the baron based on that information. He sweet-talked him into making a huge investment. In the end, he took the money and ran. That brought financial ruin to the baron.

Sir Neumann's betrayal was the trigger for the downfall of the barony.

So obviously you're subject to removal too. Lloyd gently bit his lip. The reason he couldn't comfortably live a lazy life after becoming a rural noble's oldest son. Why he was busy helping this family resolve their pile of debt. It was all the fault of this man.

However, Lloyd didn't rashly show his emotions. When he turned to Sir Neumann, his face had already mellowed into a nonchalant expression.

"Sir Neumann? What did you mean just now?"

"It's just as I said." The corner of Sir Neumann's mouth twitched. "I came here as I have something to say about the unjust violence you used against

Sir Ulrich this morning.”

“Violence. Unfair? Well, what can I say?”

“Yes.”

“Then talk.” *Go ahead and chatter away to your heart’s content.*

Lloyd laughed leisurely. Sir Neumann’s face hardened more.

“As young master Lloyd knows, Sir Ulrich is undeniably the lord’s knight. He took his oath and is entitled to the protection of his rights and honor as a knight. He is not someone you can treat carelessly based on personal feelings.”

“Hm, right.”

“Despite that, you did not respect Sir Ulrich’s honor and rights this morning in the slightest.”

“Hmm, I didn’t.”

“Therefore, as the fiefdom’s senior knight, I would like to hear your official answer. Do you feel nothing at all about the situation?”

“Hmmm, probably.”

He must’ve gotten angry. Sir Neumann’s face turned red all the way to the back of his neck. On the other hand, Lloyd’s face was still shamelessly nonchalant.

“Do my words sound like a joke to you, young master Lloyd?”

“No. They sound correct. Painfully correct.”

Sir Neumann’s eyes trembled. Lloyd put on a brighter smile. *What’s up with this guy? Is he riled up just from this?* A snort came out of Lloyd at seeing Sir Neumann’s reaction.

Honestly, this was only a low-level provocation by Lloyd's standards. But he was already angry beyond belief. *This man would die in a fit of anger if he ever played in a multiplayer online battle arena in South Korea.*

It was true. He regularly frequented the world of online combat games since he was young. That was basically the battlefield where the chaos of the century tap danced.

If you made even the smallest mistake in your position, all sorts of insults would pour out of your teammates. It was a feast of curses and barbs hurled at your character. Jokes about your parents were a given. But if you got angry over every little comment? *The person who got angry lost. You would tremble with anger and endure further ridicule until your damage meter exploded.*

It was a cold and cruel world where you could only survive by laughing off nearly any insults toward your family and responding with something worse. He was an elite veteran who trained in that hell. Actually, most gamers in Korea were.

So, the insult he threw at Sir Neumann just now? It couldn't even be considered a sly greeting. Sir Neumann, however, didn't feel that way. For him, this was one of the greatest insults he received in his life. *Who is this guy?*

It was so absurd; Sir Neumann was at a total loss for words. He fully knew from the start that Lloyd was a truly troublesome piece of trash. Still, he thought that he wasn't this bad before. Come to see that now, he realized he had been mistaken. It seemed that this insane troublemaker even looked down on him.

"Are you saying now that you will even insult me too?

"Yes, of course."

"Do you not care about my honor and rights at all?"

"Yes, of course."

“Aren’t you worried about the consequences?”

“Yes, of course.”

It was only natural. Sir Neumann was someone he needed to get rid of anyway. He was a man who sold out his lord to a swindler by the back door. Yet he was the same man who stood in front of him, speaking of his honor, rights, and so forth.

A snort escaped Lloyd. Neumann was like a phishing scam call.

Soldiers were bound by their oath to their lord. They didn’t take an oath of loyalty to the baron’s son. Thus, you couldn’t just recklessly treat the soldiers just because you were the baron’s son. It seemed Sir Neumann was trying to stir up the other soldiers using that point.

Of course, Lloyd wasn’t worried about this situation at all. *They will all be removed anyway… except Javier and Sir Bayern.*

Senior knight Sir Neumann, and his junior officers Sir Ulrich and Sir Conte. They would turn their backs on the barony once it started to crumble. He didn’t need to worry about them just because they were lashing out right now.

It’s more important at present to find an excuse to get rid of them. Lloyd looked around. Everything had quieted down. Was it because there was no one else? No, it was the opposite.

The artisans, who were cleaning up the site, had stopped working and watched what was happening in his direction. They would frantically look away and pretend to work if their eyes met. But they still kept their ears open to what was happening nearby.

Of course. A fight between the baron’s son and the senior knight is a rare sight, after all. It was a fact that the best spectacle to watch was a brawl or fight. With that truth in mind, Lloyd looked at Sir Neuman. “Then let me ask you one question.”

Sir Neumann furrowed his brows.

Lloyd asked, “You know I never learned how to handle a sword, right?”

“I am aware.”

“So can you be considered a knight if you lose a duel to me?”

“What…?” Sir Neumann’s brows twitched. Lloyd burst out laughing at that sight.

“I’m asking if you can call someone that got beaten by a complete beginner in a sword fight a knight.”

“That is…”

“They don’t have the right. It’s a fact. What is a knight’s duty? To guard the domain using sword-fighting skills they painstakingly hone every day. To protect the territory and its people in times of crisis. Isn’t that a knight’s duty and purpose?”

“If he lost a duel to someone who never learned any swordsmanship before. Could I really trust that kind of knight and let him remain employed?

“What does that…”

“I’m saying I question his qualifications.”

“But young master Lloyd…”

“I won’t hear any more protests about Sir Ulrich. Right now, I’m wondering if there’s a need to suspect and question your qualifications too as you continue defending Sir Ulrich.”

“What does that mean?” He must’ve guessed what Lloyd meant. Sir Neumann’s face completely hardened.

Lloyd laughed even harder at that sight and confirmed his suspicion. “What you’re guessing is most likely correct. You defend Sir Ulrich to an

unreasonable degree, Sir Neumann. I have fostered some doubts about your qualifications as well.”

“You can’t possibly be saying that you will challenge my skills.”

“Now you're talking.”

“There’s… no way you are challenging me to a duel.”

“But that’s correct.”

“Are you serious?”

“Of course.”

“So, will you or will you not?”

Sir Neumann’s eyes appeared nervous for the first time.

He was just trying to make a complaint to the reckless young master. He was just trying to use that as an excuse to establish his own authority. He never imagined that Lloyd Frontera, who never learned any swordsmanship, would propose a formal duel with him.

Lloyd grinned. Sir Neumann was filled with rage. The man’s response surpassed his expectations. He faithfully helped Sir Neumann make his decision. “Is this the response of the senior knight? You can’t possibly be scared to fight me, right? If you were confident, you would’ve already accepted the duel.”

“But young master Lloyd, you’re the baron’s successor and eldest son. Considering that, I can’t raise my sword at you on the pretext of a duel…”

“Is that your excuse? Your excuse is flimsy. If you’re confident in your skills, you should easily and safely be able to overpower me. Do you not even have the confidence to do that? I’m disappointed. This is why I can’t help but have doubts about your qualifications.”

“Have you finished speaking…?”

“No. I’m not done.”

“I think people like you are the most pitiful. Senior knight? A man who won’t prove his abilities, nor has the courage or confidence to do so, hangs onto his title to wield power. Isn’t that embarrassing even when you think about it?”

“What does everyone else think?” All the attention turned toward Sir Neumann, who had his mouth closed. Lloyd loudly asked the soldiers nearby the question.

At that moment, Sir Neumann made a cackling sound. Lloyd laughed inwardly. *Of course.*

He received the insult right to his face. But the fact that people around them heard it was more humiliating. That was how people thought. It was the same when someone was being reprimanded. If they were scolded in a quiet place, that was the end of it. But if it happened in front of everyone, especially their subordinates? They would promptly break down.

And right now, that effect was showing. “Understood…” Sir Neumann reluctantly answered.

Lloyd’s mouth stretched into a smile as if he was waiting for this.

“You will do it? The duel?”

“Yes.”

“Good decision. You should resolve your disputes like a man. When would be a good date?”

“Young master can decide that.”

“One month from now. The location is the estate’s training hall. How about it?”

“That is fine.” Sir Neumann nodded his rigid face. “Then is there anything you would demand, based on the outcome of the duel?”

“Of course there is.”

Lloyd put forth his preplanned answer. “I will banish you if I win our duel that day.”

“What?”

“I will remove you from your position and drive you out.”

“Do you have any reason to dispute?”

“No, I don’t. However.”

“However?”

“Young master should get a corresponding outcome.”

“All right. I will bet on my position as well.”

“Your position?”

“My inheritance to this barony as the eldest son, I will give that up.”

“Are you serious?”

“Of course.” Lloyd nodded his head without hesitation. “Don’t worry. I speak the truth. The soldiers here will stand as witnesses. You should just train hard, so you don’t get wrecked like Sir Ulrich.”

“Those words, I hope you don’t come to regret them.”

“Not at all.”

That was how the duel was arranged. Of course he had no regrets. He had already found his secret to victory. To say it directly, he was going to ruthlessly get rid of everyone who stood in his way.

***

Two hours later

“So do you have confidence that you can win?”

“No, not much.”

“I see.” Javier nodded his head. He had been unusually absent from Lloyd’s side all day. It couldn’t be helped. There was an order from Lord Frontera. *He had called me in the morning and then ordered me to stop escorting young master Lloyd for just today.*

He didn’t know exactly why, but he could guess from what he heard that Lloyd did in his absence today. *Something like he made an excuse to assault Sir Ulrich, then proposed a duel with Sir Neumann who had come to protest what happened.*

He wondered if Lloyd pushed him away today to do those things. That’s what Javier was speculating. He felt a strange emotion. *Why?*

He couldn’t understand. Why did he agitate the soldiers who weren’t doing anything? Why did he assault Sir Ulrich and propose a duel with Sir Neumann? *Is he just causing trouble again?*

That might have seemed like the case at first glance. Although Lloyd had been acting differently recently, the truth was people didn’t change easily. Considering that, it could look like he was throwing a fit because of his bad temper. However, Lloyd didn’t think that was it. *His actions are too intentional to say he’s just throwing a fit.*

Lloyd pushed him away from his side. After he assaulted Sir Ulrich, he entrusted Sir Bayern with the construction site. When Sir Neumann came to him in a fury, he challenged him to a duel like he was waiting for him. But what was Lloyd’s attitude after causing all this commotion? He was shamelessly nonchalant. It was an attitude he couldn’t have unless he intentionally caused these events. *Furthermore, he certainly has an agenda, considering his recent actions…*

That was when Javier stopped thinking. Lloyd's voice broke his train of thought.

"Hey, you. What do you mean, 'I see'? That's all?"

"What do you mean, 'that's all'?"

"What else would I mean? Your reaction."

Lloyd, who was having dinner, looked up and slightly tilted his head to one side.

"You wanted to know whether I'm confident of winning a duel against Sir Neumann. What was my answer?"

"You said you were not confident."

"Right?"

"Yes."

"And you're only replying to it with, 'I see'? Seriously? You don't have anything to say, like how you're worried about something, why would I ever do this, and so on?

"I'm not sure why I need to show that sort of reaction."

"You're my guard."

"That is correct… however."

"However?"

"I believe you were the one who proposed the duel, young master."

"Humph, so you mean a duel isn't included in your services as a guard?"

"Of course." It was only natural. What was a duel for, after all? "A duel is the most fair and direct method to resolve a conflict where the disputing

parties are stripped of their normal social status and position to stand on an equal playing field to fight each other. As such, I don’t have the power or duty to interfere with the duel between the young master and Sir Neumann.”

“Hmm, I suppose that’s how it is, right?”

“Yes.”

“Well then, how about you teach me swordsmanship during the month before the duel?”

“Are you asking if I will teach you, young master Lloyd?”

“Yes.”

“I don’t want to.”

“Why?”

“Because I’m not personally inclined to.”

It was an honest answer. Whatever happened, he was just his guard. He had no duty to teach swordsmanship to a rowdy young master he didn’t particularly like. *And he might go around causing bigger trouble if I pointlessly teach him how to wield a sword.* Thus, he felt more strongly that he shouldn’t teach him. So, he wondered why the young master, who he just sharply turned down, had a wicked smile.

“Really?”

Something felt off. An ominous feeling spread through Javier’s body. Lloyd's expression was disquieting. His eyes somehow looked like they knew something about him. His smile seemed to say Javier would act as he intended.

In the end, the ominous feeling became a reality.

“If you give me lessons on swordsmanship…”

Lloyd’s eyes glinted.

“I will cure your insomnia.” Lloyd smiled brightly. “How about it?”

Javier swallowed dryly without Lloyd knowing. Severe chronic insomnia. It was his hidden weakness and a secret that had been torturing him for several years.

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Chapter 10: The Determined Troublemaker (1)

“I will cure your insomnia. How about it?”

Javier unconsciously clenched his fists. He wondered if this was what it felt like to be hit In the head with a hammer out of nowhere. *How does Master Lloyd know about my insomnia?*

The insomnia that started torturing him years ago. He never revealed it before. He never told a single soul. He never even remembered showing any signs of it.

Javier gave an awkward smile and said, “I’m not sure what you mean. Insomnia? Where does that come from? I have no idea what you are talking about?”

“Hm, really?”

“Yes.”

“Tsk. tsk, tsk. Javier, are you trying to pretend you don’t know?”

“Of course not.”

“You’re not?”

“Yes.”

“Then why are you smiling? Very awkwardly, at that.”

“What?”

“Did you know? This is the first time you’ve smiled in front of me other than when you put on your cheeky grin.”

“Oh my. Look at you, wiping off your smile after I point it out. You’re making it too obvious. Did you panic? Tsk, tsk, tsk… over something so small. I can see through it, so drop the act. Let’s just get this one thing

straight. I will cure your insomnia. In return, you will teach me how to sword fight. How about it? I think that is a pretty good deal."

Javier swallowed dryly. Honestly, he was startled. Chronic insomnia. It was an illness that has tortured him for three years now. The reason or cause for it is unknown. His senses just became overly sensitive at some point.

The idle sound of grasshoppers. The sound of branches swaying in the wind. Even the rustling sound of him tossing and turning under a blanket.

The sounds heard with his ears, the sights seen by his eyes. The sensations on his skin. Even the subtle smell of the air in every breath he took.

He could clearly pick up on all of them.

It was to the point where he could feel his individual eyelashes when he closed his eyes. The sound of his heart beating in his ears prodded him every second of every day.

Short version: his senses pricked his entire body like needles twenty-four hours a day.

He couldn't fall asleep at all. By this point, he got all his sleep from eventually passing out in exhaustion in the early morning after tossing and turning all night.

There were no solutions. Nothing worked. And he'd tried everything.

Three years had already gone by.

It was a pain he struggled with in secret and a bug he couldn't reveal for fear it'd become a weakness. His wish was to sleep soundly for even one night. *But he knows? The troublesome young master? How?* Javier's face set as if it were frozen in a block of ice.

Lloyd's gaze turned sly. *How else? It's because I read the book.*

Javier was the protagonist of the novel *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Lloyd had read it thoroughly and memorized the contents. He remembered even

the most trivial details about Javier… Such as his insomnia.

You probably don't know the cause of the insomnia that's torturing you. But I know. Swordmaster syndrome. That was the cause of the illness. *As your swordsmanship approaches master level, all your senses become abnormally acute. Simply put, it's a natural phenomenon that occurs to those who are reaching a superhuman state of being.*

It was the same in Javier's case. He was able to become an advanced swordsman at only seventeen. As he developed, so did his affliction. He spent every night tossing and turning in misery. But for a long time, he still couldn't find the cause. That was because of only one reason, Javier was from the countryside.

Forget a sword master, I can barely find a sword novice in this rural wasteland. No, I would likely find three or four high-level sword experts at most, even if I searched the kingdom's capital. That was why he couldn't easily come across information about sword master syndrome.

If this world had internet access, he would've easily found the information by just searching on the web. But this place was different. They could only obtain knowledge through limited personal connections or books. Otherwise, it would be delivered by word of mouth, which was hard to validate. Outside those methods, there was no other way to acquire new information.

For that reason, Javier in the novel finally finds the cause of his insomnia two years from now. From then, it's only after three years that Javier overcomes his insomnia by coincidence.

I can make it happen earlier. He knew how to. He knew for sure.

"I will succeed. Your thoughts?"

"Do I have to answer?"

"Well, you aren't obligated to," Lloyd said, as he stabbed his salad with a fork. "Don't misunderstand. I'm not trying to fool you. I'm just saying you

should trust me this once.”

“Trust you, Master Lloyd?”

“Yes. Good is good, after all. People trust each other in situations like this. Building a constructive relationship through trust. Helping each other during hard times. That’s just how it goes in work and life in general, isn’t it? Why is your face so sour? Do I seem like a hustler when I talk like this?”

“If I’m being honest, you do seem like one a bit.”

“Am I that untrustworthy?”

“Yes.” Javier nodded his head.

Lloyd licked his lips. “Then how about we do this? Let’s play a word game.”

“Did you say, ‘a word game’?”

“Yes. Let’s give it a try to build some trust between us. Give me a letter and I’ll come up with a word.”

“What…”

“All right, so… start with the letter M. Now… go!”

Javier looked at him blankly.

“Hurry.”

“…M…”

“My loyal knight Javier, do you not trust me?”

“Maybe.”

“An acrostic poem out of nowhere. You were mistaken if you thought these schemes would easily work on me. More importantly, I would like to ask a

question too.”

“Hmm, tsk. What is it?”

“I was wondering why you were carrying around a summoning book all day.” Javier gazed toward the table in front of Lloyd. The basic summoning book. It was what Lloyd was reading while having his meal.

“Oh, this?” Lloyd smirked. “I was just reading it because I got bored.”

“Excuse me?”

“I was just reading it. Is that not allowed?”

Javier closed his mouth.

Lloyd’s smile got bigger. “Javier, I can see through you too easily. Is this how you’re trying to change the topic?”

“I merely asked what I was curious about.”

“Never mind. Just continue what you were saying.”

Javier remained silent.

“So, you can’t trust me?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“I don’t have a specific reason.”

“You just can’t trust me?”

“Yes. I just can’t trust you. Is that not allowed?”

It was a counterattack. As expected, Javier wasn’t easy to deal with. Lloyd brightly smiled. “You think that was a sick burn, right?”

“I didn’t have that thought in particular.”

“Really?”

“Yes. I only gave you an honest answer.”

“Well, all right. Then let’s end our conversation here today.”

“What do you mean by our conversation?”

“We can finish our conversation tomorrow.” Lloyd set down his fork and finished his meal. Afterward, he leaned back on a resting chair and fully concentrated on reading the summoning book. He didn’t even spare Javier a glance. He didn’t talk to him either, of course. It was the same when the maids cleaned up the table and for a while afterward too. Only the sound of turning pages filled the bedroom.

Meanwhile, Javier faithfully guarded Lloyd’s side. His expression was a little more complicated than usual.

The night grew darker.

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A few days passed.

During that time, the heated flooring construction went by smoothly.

The soldiers moved in perfect order under Lord Bayern’s proper supervision. These were the soldiers who could barely move the red clay on the first day. But they transformed in a few days. They gained stamina. Their muscles grew bigger. They also became more savvy. Now, they could easily move two sacks at once. It was thanks to the adequate amount of work, rest, and nutrition they got.

The artisans acquired many more skills. They were like a sponge soaking up water or orange chicken absorbing sauce through its batter. They quickly learned the new knowledge and ideas Lloyd taught them.

That was how the construction of the first house was completed successfully. Things got even easier with the construction of the second house. There was no longer a need to stay on site all day. He just needed to visit the site once a day to check that everything was in good shape, the construction was going according to the floor plan, there wasn't anything missing, and no mistakes were made. The job ran smoothly with just a general inspection.

Thanks to that there was plenty of leftover time to use productively. He used the time to bother Javier.

"Did you sleep well last night?"

"Yes, I slept soundly."

"Really?"

"Yes."

"You really can't lie."

"Are you talking about me?"

"Yes."

"That couldn't be."

"Yeah, right. Did you know? You make it very obvious when you lie."

"I'm not sure what you're talking about in particular."

"You want me to tell you? I don't want to. If I do, you're going to put on a facade so as not to show anything."

"I won't."

"You won't?"

"Yes." Javier momentarily avoided his eyes as he answered.

As he thought, this guy really had no skill for lying. Lloyd smiled brightly. “I still don’t want to. I’m not going to tell someone who has insomnia. How dare you act up when you can’t even sleep. Do you feel bad? Are you sad? Then accept my proposal.”

“No thank you.”

“I said I’ll help you sleep soundly.”

“I don’t want to even then.”

“Because you can’t trust me?”

“Yes.”

That was how the conversation went. However, Lloyd didn’t give up. He suddenly asked during breakfast: “Hey, Javier?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“Did you sleep well last night? How about accepting my proposal now?”

“No thank you.”

He asked again while walking down the hallway. “By the way, Javier.”

“Go ahead, Master Lloyd.”

“Is it all right to keep losing sleep? That’s why I’m saying to accept my proposal.”

“I refuse.”

He asked again on the way to inspect the construction site. “Oh, right. Javier?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“How does it feel to not be able to sleep all night? Aren’t you starting to have thoughts about accepting my proposal?”

“Not at all.”

He popped in the question during dinner too. “Hmm. Javier?”

“Go ahead…”

“Do you possibly enjoy not being able to sleep? Do you get a rush of endorphins? Do you get a kick out of it? Well, then you’re a pervert.”

He even abruptly asked again while he was lying down in bed to sleep. “Ugh, Javier? You won’t be able to sleep tonight too, right? I’ll sleep soundly in your stead. Aren’t you grateful? Happy? ‘Excuse me, Sir?’ Please answer instead of cursing me out with your eyes.”

“Ha ha… very well then.”

“What do you mean very well?”

“I will accept your proposal, Master Lloyd.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd bolted up.

Javier bit his lip. He was beyond tired of it now. The constant pestering throughout the day was killing him. It was almost impossible to even doze off because of his frazzled nerves. *Of course, it’s not like I trust Master Lloyd’s proposal.* Lloyd Frontera was not a very reliable person. But to put an end to the constant ridicule and questions? He thought this was the only way to stop it. “Regardless of anything, this acceptance is contingent on the promise that you actually will cure my insomnia. So, curing my insomnia is the priority.”

Obviously, there was no possibility it would be cured. He had no hopes that Lloyd would have that kind of ability. It was better to just accept the proposal and let him fail. Making him give up like this seemed easier. *Since I don't want to teach him how to sword fight.*

He couldn't trust Lloyd. Until a few days ago, Lloyd was someone who did nothing but drink every day and cause trouble. Although he did change a little recently, it was uncertain how long this would last. There was no knowing when his bad habits would raise their head again. *Yet, teach that kind of person how to sword fight? It's nonsense.*

He thought it would be better to hand a knife to a child. With that thought in mind, he spoke. "As such, please prove that you can cure my insomnia first, Master Lloyd."

"All right, I will. Can you sit here for now?"

"Yes."

Javier sat down on the resting chair as Lloyd ordered, and then inwardly snorted. It was because he saw Lloyd clearing his throat. *Could it be he's going to sing me a lullaby or something?* A lullaby. It wasn't even funny anymore. At the same time, he became certain there was no way he would experience an unbelievable miracle and sleep soundly tonight.

But the moment Lloyd opened his mouth his certainty started to splinter.

"If the yield strength of the steel, fy, is stressed to conduct the tensile test and results in a less than 0.003 strain rate, then the reinforcement's design strength can be maintained without decreasing fy."

What…? Javier couldn't understand a word being said. He was talking normally. It wasn't like he was speaking in some mysterious foreign tongue. Meaning they were speaking the same language. But he couldn't understand anything he said. And, he kept on talking like that!

"…However, the yield strength cannot be greater than 5,500kgf/ . This is because when the yield strength of the steel is 5,500kgf/ , the yield strain is

almost the same as the 0.003 maximum strain rate of the compacted concrete. And…”

He had blanked out while listening to something. This was definitely a reality, but he felt like his mind was drifting away.

“And the amount of steel … blah, blah, blah … Except for the slabs that require reinforcement…yada, yada, yada… The reinforcement ratio, P, in its given cross-sectional area… this or that… The maximum reinforcement ratio, P, has to be over min=14/fy … blah, blah, blah…”

He felt drowsy. His entire body was floating. His consciousness was slipping away. The line between reality and imagination became blurry. Resistance was pointless. Even if he tried to pry open his eyes. Even if he tried to sluggishly move his fingers. Nothing would work. *I can’t… fall… asleep…*

“…Over here the unit of fy is kgf/ … The reason for the minimum reinforcement ratio… more gibberish… In order to prevent flexural failure… If the reinforced flexural, 0.10$f$ck A…la-la-la…

This was the power that reading a college textbook had that was even more destructive than sleeping pills.

That was the end.

Javier’s eyes relaxed. His eyelids closed. His consciousness flew away. He sank into the resting chair. Before he knew it, he was sound asleep.

A smile of satisfaction spread across Lloyd’s face. *As expected, it’s just like the scene in the novel.*

That day Javier overcame his insomnia for the first time. On that day, he coincidentally heard the reading of a complex magic technique. The quiet and never-ending reading made him fall asleep before he realized it.

Just like now.

Javier would never again be able to forget the feeling of a restful good night's sleep he experienced today. His body would no longer be able to sleep without a college textbook lullaby.

Lloyd put on a satisfied yet wicked smile. *Your swordsmanship is all mine now.*

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Chapter 11: The Determined Troublemaker (2)

I'm tired and sleepy.

Javier scowled as he tossed and turned on a comfortable chair. He wanted to sleep a little more, and nothing was surprising about that, given his schedule. In the afternoon, he protected the troublemaking young master. At night, he laid on the bed only to stay awake through the night because of insomnia. And, in between the breaks he rarely had, he trained himself to stay sharp with his sword. Thus, it was only natural that he was exhausted.

No, it was almost karma. *I think I dozed fairly longer than on other days.* Javier strangely felt that he slept longer than usual. So, he smiled, satisfied that he was able to get some rest. But a voice interrupted his state of momentary euphoria.

"Haven't you slept enough…?"

The stranger's words sounded mocking to Javier's ears. But at the same time, they didn't sound mean spirited. *Am I dreaming?*

But he immediately knew that it wasn't a dream because he hadn't dreamed for the past couple years. *I'm probably hearing things due to sleep deprivation.* Javier flopped himself in the other direction to silence the voice.

But the voice came again.

"It's late. Time to wake up, sleepyhead."

What the…? It's not a dream. The voice was definitely coming from right beside him.

I'm a sleepyhead? No way… The grogginess was starting to fade, and clarity was returning gradually. He recalled how he had been suffering from insomnia for many years now. So, there was no way someone would call him sleepyhead. Plus, he had exceptionally sharp senses. They picked up on

this stranger's movement and woke Javier even before they had time to walk over to his side and speak in his ear.

He snapped open his eyes to see who it was. He scanned the room, and he felt his body stiffen.

"Finally awake? Sheesh, if I didn't get you up, you'd be waking up when the sun is shining over you."

Standing beside his chair was a young man with black hair. He looked like he was in his mid-twenties. The guy was looking at him with a playful expression. But at the same time, it looked menacing and mischievous, like the face of a naughty kid who discovered the nicest toy in the world.

"Master Lloyd…?" Javier found himself muttering, as the pieces began to snap together in his head. The guy standing in front of him was the young master he protected. The beast and menace of the fiefdom. The very man who for some reason had been acting very strange in recent days.

Lloyd smirked as he looked at Javier. Javier didn't like it.

"At last, you recognize me. I'm truly honored," Lloyd mocked. *Honored.…? He doesn't look a tad bit honored.*

"But sir, why are you waking me up…?" Javier didn't mean to mutter, but his words came out all jumbled and mixed. He was too dazed and confused. Everything was in a blur.

Why is this guy waking me up? This has never happened before. Javier thought to himself. It was impossible. *It was that snake Lloyd that always slept in, and I had to wake him up every single morning without exception.* So, it was a wonder for Javier to see his young master proudly standing beside him, smirking triumphantly.

"What do you mean, why? You fell asleep here," Lloyd stated.

"I did? Here?" Javier's eyes widened for a second.

"Yes."

“Why?”

“Hey, don’t you remember what happened last night?”

“But last night, I was…”

“Passed out. Totally passed out,” Lloyd interrupted. “And you slept like a baby. You snored and ground your teeth in your sleep. You know, I thought I was in the middle of a night at the opera or something.”

“Yeah, I understand. The concrete lecture does that to people. I almost lost it when I took that class,” Lloyd admitted in an emphatic voice. “I was even getting sleepy myself as I was reading the lecture out loud.”

I don’t know what happened… I can’t remember anything. Really. I just leaned on this chair, and that was it. Last night was a blur, but Javier was certain of one thing: Now his head felt clear and light. He couldn’t believe he got a good night’s sleep. It was a marvelous and unknown experience.

“Tsk. I guess you’re still groggy. Here, drink this. It will wake you up.” Lloyd held out a glass. The cold clear water undulated in it.

After gulping the drink down, Javier inspected his body. He clenched his fists. He felt strong and revitalized. Which was something he did not feel the day before. He could feel the blood coursing through his clenched fists. He felt alive and refreshed, so very unlike the endless days when sleep deprivation wore him down. *This is amazing. Did I really sleep well and defeat that hellish insomnia?*

Although it seemed like an impossibility, Javier decided to accept this new reality. After all, his body was the proof. Being an excellent swordsman, he decided to trust the signs from his body. But just then, something caught his eye.

“What is that?” Javier was gazing at Lloyd, particularly at his waist. A wooden sword was hanging down at his side. There was more. The young master’s outfit was different from usual. He was wearing sturdy leather

armor on top of his daily outfit. Leather protective pads were strapped around his knees and elbows. And a towel was draped around his neck.

Javier had the impression that his young master was all set, ready to take action, whatever that action was. *Wait a second. Is he…?* Javier involuntarily sucked in his breath, because he felt something ominous was coming his way, and he was correct.

“Did you forget already? We agreed that you’d teach me how to use a sword if I cured your insomnia,” Lloyd said matter-of-factly.

Lloyd’s confident voice called to mind what the event of the night before was. Last night, Javier took Lloyd’s offer. It was a kind of bet. The two made a deal that Javier would teach his vulgar young master the way of the sword if he helped him overcome insomnia and get a good night’s sleep. Lloyd made the offer, and Javier agreed to it. *What? Now I have to teach this jerk how to fight with a sword? Me?*

He wasn’t celebrating anymore that he had finally won the battle against insomnia and tasted the sweet victory of restful sleep.

Now he was in deep trouble.

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“We will start with running,” Javier announced.

They were in the training hall with plenty of sunlight. Standing on one side of the hall, Javier continued. “Please stand over here. Good. You will be running laps around the hall. Do you have any questions?”

“No. What’s there to it? It’s just running.” Lloyd looked at Javier with a quizzical look. “Hold on, you weren’t going to pep-talk me, were you?” Lloyd asked.

“Pep talk? I don’t know what you mean.”

“Oh, come on. You know how coaches and trainers put on their solemn faces and say, ‘all training boils down to the basics, like running. The

powerful slashes and impressive techniques must be backed by strong stamina and basic strength.' And blah, blah, blah."

Feeling exposed, Javier shut his mouth.

Lloyd shrugged. "And don't tell me that you pictured me refusing to run and whining to get on to the sword fighting right away," Lloyd continued. "And then you would reject me in a solemn voice that it was me who wanted to learn the sword in the first place, not you. Is that what you imagined?"

"Crap, I am right." Lloyd shook his head. "Whew. What are you, a baby? Tsk. I'm off now." With that, Lloyd began to jog.

Left alone at the starting line, Javier furrowed his brow. *I really thought he would complain that he couldn't run.*

The young master's reaction was completely different from what he expected. He was very cooperative, even. *But I'm sure his true colors will show if I just make him keep running.*

Javier was certain. He was certain that everyone brims with confidence when they first try something out. They imagine that they could do it. That the goal was near. That they were almost there.

But at the moment they need to overcome their physical and mental limits. Their initial confidence and bravado dissipate like they never existed. They made compromises because things weren't easy anymore. And, at last, they proved to the world that they were weak and fragile by giving up. Much like those who went on a diet only to start snacking again four days later. Like those smokers who started smoking a day after telling their friends that they'd quit.

Lloyd Frontera. You're no different. Javier knew his young master. He had no experience of this kind of situation… where he was forced to run. Javier could already picture what was going to happen after a few laps. *He's going to regret being so arrogant. He might even ditch this whole thing and call off our deal.*

Honestly, Javier direly wished that he would call it off. He didn’t want to teach swordsmanship to that jackass. He couldn’t trust his young master. After all, Lloyd was a drunk whose sole purpose in life was to get wasted. And he caused a riot every time he got loaded.

Javier flinched a little when he imagined the kinds of troubles that lush would get into once he learned how to use a sword. *I can never let that happen.*

Sure, his sadistic drunken ways had mellowed in the past few days. But one’s nature doesn't change that easily. He told himself it must be the same for Master Lloyd. For all anyone knew, his old habits could live again today. *I’m going to treat you as harshly as possible. I will do so until you get exhausted and quit. Or, until you overcome your nature and prove that you are worthy of my efforts.*

Javier resolved that he would put his foot down on this.

He gazed icily at Lloyd, and he waited. He would wait until Lloyd gave up. But things didn’t go as he planned.

Lloyd kept running. Without any words, he ran. He ran ten laps, then twenty, thirty… On and on, he ran. He passed Javier dozens of times. Yet he never voiced a word of complaint. Not even once.

He was out of breath. He was sweaty all over. His legs staggered in exhaustion. Yet he continued to run without a break, never slowing down.

But how? Javier thought. Javier’s eyes trembled in disbelief. He tried to hide it at first but didn’t even bother after a while. He couldn’t wrap his head around the young master’s mental strength. His tenacity was inconceivable, and Javier wanted to know where it was coming from.

However, to Lloyd, the secret was plain and simple. He had done countless things that were more physically demanding than simply running laps.

It was true.

During the time he was in the military, he had to undergo an exhausting number of marches and training. It was even worse when his parents passed away, and he had to make a living doing part-time jobs.

One time, he spent a whole day carrying bricks on his back up to the fourth floor of a house for a construction job. Then there was the time he loaded and unloaded the boxes and goods that went in and out of a warehouse all through the night.

Only those who went through such struggles knew what it felt like. During those times, Lloyd felt like his body was morphing into a gear in a machine. His muscles felt like they were on the brink of disintegrating after being endlessly used and abused.

Then, when he reached the point where breathing became a chore, he would look hopefully at his watch. He'd tell himself that it would be over soon, that it was almost time for a break. However, the reality he always faced was nothing but… a world of shit. Whenever he looked at his watch, he would see that not even half the time had passed! So, compared to the miserable days when he had to grind and hustle to earn some money, running around the hall was the same as being up in the sweet heaven above.

That was Lloyd's life back in Korea. Every day was a stifling struggle back then. Misery and despair assaulted his thoughts, and he constantly wondered, *How long do I have to live like this?*

And yet… he couldn't give up because he had to survive.

For just a few pennies…

Just to make ends meet…

He had to overcome his limits all the time. Even when he couldn't push himself anymore, he had to keep moving like a zombie. That was the only way he would not starve. But now, it was simple. *I just have to run, and that's it.*

He wasn’t moving because he had to. He was moving and running because he wanted to learn how to use the sword.

Sure, his body was sore. But he was happy and enjoying himself. He was out of breath and covered in sweat. His legs were losing strength. The world was becoming a smudge in front of his eyes from lack of oxygen. Despite all of this, he was happy.

Lloyd kept running.

When he reached fifty laps, Lloyd grinned at Javier as he passed by. “Hey, Javier, I’m the one who’s running, so why does your face look so bad?”

Another lap.

“Hey, don’t tell me I totally shattered your expectations.”

Another lap.

“Fine, keep staring into space then.”

Another lap.

And Lloyd continued running.

Finally, Javier stopped him. “Master Lloyd, please stop running.”

“W-why?”

“You’re exhausted and staggering.”

“I know…I know that. So?”

“So, take a rest.”

“Whew. Okay. Fine.”

At last, he stopped.

“Did I fluster you?” Lloyd asked as he caught his breath.

“No.”

“No, my foot. You are. You are flustered. Ha… Fine. I guess you didn’t see this coming,” Lloyd said and paused for a second. “I’m pretty sure that you got here ready to tell me something like, ‘Master Lloyd, I am disappointed in your lack of determination,’ or ‘Master Lloyd, you have to keep running until I tell you to stop.’ Tell me I’m wrong.”

Javier looked at Lloyd without a word.

“I told you this before, but you’re pretty judgmental.”

“I’m not sure what you mean.”

“Did you think I was joking when I asked you to teach me swordsmanship?” Lloyd said, gazing coldly at him. The smile was gone from his lips.

Javier couldn’t come up with an answer when he met his gaze. He felt exposed.

“Is swordsmanship a joke to you? Is that it?” Lloyd demanded.

“Of course it’s not.”

“Then why didn’t you take me seriously when I asked you to teach me?”

“That’s…”

“You think you can teach me with that lax attitude of yours?”

Javier was struck speechless again. For the first time in his life, he wanted to run away and hide. The jabs from the young master — who he dismissed as a mere troublemaker — continued to stab him in the heart.

“Come to think of it, I should be assessing whether you’re qualified to teach me how to use the sword, not the other way around. Am I wrong? So

please, let’s do it right. Instead of arguing whether I’m worthy or not, spend your time finding out how to teach better. Got that?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes…” Javier bit his bottom lip involuntarily.

I can’t believe I got scolded by that good-for-nothing. It felt like a smack in the head. He wanted to deny it. But he could not.

I can’t because he is right. Javier accepted that he was in the wrong. He was more concerned if Lloyd was even worthy of being his student. He couldn’t care less about instructing him properly. Just as his young master pointed out.

He was unprepared to teach, yet he wanted to see if his young master had what it took to be his student. Javier felt ashamed as he reflected on his attitude.

Just then…

Ding dong.

A new message popped up in front of Lloyd.

[Your approval rating with Javier Asrahan has increased by one point.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: -28]

[You have earned 18 RP by improving relationships with main characters.]

[Current RP: 29]

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Chapter 12: The Asrahan Core Technique (1)

Sword training continued over the following few days.

Nothing exceptional took place.

As in the first session, Lloyd ran repeatedly around the training hall. When he had the time, he learned how to hold the sword, get into a fighting stance, and use his feet. The training mainly centered on the basics. But Lloyd didn't gripe even once. He never demanded that Javier move on to the powerful techniques that are useful in actual combat. He simply gave himself entirely over to the training.

Javier was surprised to see this. But he wasn't alone. The people in the barony were equally surprised.

"The young master spent the whole day training, again?" a maid said.

"Yeah, He didn't complain once. From morning to night," another yawped.

"Good gracious. Even though he comes home exhausted every day…"

"I know, right? I can hardly believe what I'm seeing."

"Me too. This makes no sense."

"What do you mean?"

"Hmm, do you think he might be ill?" The maid's voice sounded wary.

"Ill? How so?"

"I mean, mentally ill."

"You mean, he's lost it?" Another maid spoke.

"Yes, yes. It looks like it."

“You have a point…”

This kind of talk among the maids became common on the estate. The soldiers were just as confused as the maids were.

“What do you think is wrong with the young master?”

“Eh? Be specific,” a soldier said.

“I mean, he seems a bit strange. Doesn't he? Have you seen him drink lately?”

“Oh my, I don’t think I have?!” He exclaimed.

“Right?”

“Huh. Now that you mention it… I don’t think I’ve seen him drink for at least two weeks.”

“Wow,” another soldier paused for a second. “Wait a second.”

“What is it?”

“I know it sounds absurd, but I have a possible explanation.”

“What?”

“Maybe Lloyd is taking drugs in secret.”

“Drugs?”

“Uh-huh.” The soldier nodded.

“Yeah, but what kind?”

“What do you mean by what kind of drugs? The drugs,” the guy emphasized.

“What!?” he exclaimed in disbelief.

“Shh. Lower your voice. Hear me out,” he leaned over to make sure no one was listening. “This man, who did nothing but drink every day, quit overnight. And, he spends all day training in the hall. What else is there? It’s the drugs in him that give him the energy.”

“Come on… You’re being absurd.”

“No, I’m not. There is a kind that helps the user get hyper-focused. He might be taking that. That’s what’s keeping him in one piece despite the training.”

“Right? How else would that piece of trash be able to train so hard? Uh, uhm… Shush.”

“What is it?”

“Behind you… behind,” he muttered.

“Behind…? Oh… how are you today, Baroness Frontera!”

The soldiers guarding the front gate bowed when they saw Baroness Frontera walking toward them. She smiled elegantly.

“Very well. I hope you are doing very well, too,” she cooed gently.

“Th-thank you, madame.”

“Here. Could you give my son this towel when he returns from training?”

“Yes, madame.”

“Thank you. It must be boring to guard the gates, mustn’t it?”

“Pardon me?”

“Gossip is an excellent distraction to help alleviate boredom. However, please mind the subject of your discussions. After all, he is my son,” she said with a reserved sternness in her voice.

“We will keep that in mind, madame…”

So, Lloyd found himself at the center of estate gossip. The maids concluded that he was mentally ill. The soldiers, on the other hand, believed that he was taking drugs. Lloyd’s parents were happy and concerned at the same time about their son. All the while, Lloyd continued his training without a hitch.

Like everyone else, Javier was equally stupefied. *It’s as if he’s become a different person overnight.*

He trained from morning to night. It was a hectic and hellish regimen. He ran and even rolled on the ground all day. He brandished his sword in the same position innumerable times. The skin around his palms scraped and peeled, leaving calluses and bloody scabs.

And yet, he doesn’t complain. He’s enjoying it instead. Initially, Javier was convinced that Lloyd’s cockiness would disappear after a few days. But he had since changed his mind. Rather, he became concerned over the young master’s injuries. Lloyd’s determination was too strong. Javier watched over Lloyd’s training with great anxiety. And when Lloyd seemed to have reached his tipping point, Javier jumped in and forced him to rest.

How is it possible for a person to change this drastically? How is he no longer the wild drunk who lived only to drink another bottle and take his rage out on innocent people?

And where did he pick up all those strange stories he recites every night? Every night Lloyd prattled on about concrete, stress points, and so many other things Javier couldn’t remember because he would fall fast asleep. It didn’t sound like a magic spell, but it worked. Though he could barely remember the gibberish, it put him to good, happy sleep.

It could be something academic. Whatever it is, it’s more potent than sleeping pills. The only thing he had to do was just sit back and relax. After a few words, Javier passed out. He could fall asleep without worry. Lloyd’s ability to put him to sleep was beyond surprising. It was magical.

Javier furrowed his brow.

Who is he? Really, who is he? His indecent past was filled with disappointments. But his decent present was filled with surprises. The huge gap between the two stopped Javier from crediting it to a mere change of attitude. *It would make more sense if another soul came to be in Lloyd's body*, Javier thought to himself.

Though it would be completely absurd… Javier shook his head.

He shouted to Lloyd, who was on his 30th lap of runs. "That is enough, Master Lloyd."

"Whew. Already? I can run some more," Lloyd said as he panted for air.

"I know that."

"But why did you stop me?"

"I'm thinking about moving to the next step."

"Next step?"

"Mana reaction training."

"Whoa!" The corners of Lloyd's lips rose.

This was the moment he had been waiting for.

I was starting to get bored with basic training. Lloyd had been running for many days now, never complaining that he wanted to move up to the next level.

That was mainly because he was reaping the benefits of enduring the strenuous workout. His skin tone brightened. There was more vitality in his body. When he woke up in the morning, he felt refreshed and strong. On top of that, thanks to the commitment he demonstrated to others, he earned quite a lot of additional RP.

I've earned quite a lot. I already have 97 RP. In the last few days, his approval rating increased by one point with Javier. That got Lloyd 18 RP. And the approval rating with his father and mother increased by two and three points, respectively, bagging him 20 and 30 RP.

Lloyd was getting the hang of this RP system.

So, for every increase by one of my approval rating, I get 18 RP with Javier. As for my fictional parents, it's 10 RP for every approval rating increase. I guess that means the characters in the novel give out different RP. He concluded that the higher the significance of the characters in the story, the more RP he would get.

This means that I should work hard to get liked by Javier. As for the baron and baroness… they were a surprise. The novel hardly mentioned the baron and baroness in the story. To put it bluntly, they were only extras in the introduction. So, it came as a surprise that they would render more than half of the RP Javier gives out. This meant they could have a greater role in this world that has yet to be revealed.

Anyway, I'm finally proceeding to mana reaction training. The upcoming lessons filled his heart with expectation. *I need to start reinforcing my mana now, so I can beat Sir Neumann.*

The duel was fifteen days away.

He knew that he wouldn't be able to reach the level of skill required to conjure a manaheart in such a short period of time. It took a tremendous amount of work before one could create a manaheart. More than ten years for a person lacking any skills. Around five years for an average person. A gifted person would take two, while a genius may require six months to be able to use it. Even under the dedicated training of a learned master, that was how long it took to develop a manaheart.

But Javier reaches the level in a day. And he does that all by himself. What a monster. Lloyd was thinking about it when Javier spoke.

“Surely, it is in your best interest to curb your hopes that you will be able to develop a manaheart as soon as you reinforce and strengthen your mana. You need to take this one step at a time. In any case, you will see your body getting stronger by simple training of mana reinforcement.” Javier continued to speak. “Please, take your seat here.”

“This way?”

“Yes. Please relax. Lose the tension around your shoulders,” Javier urged.

“Will this do?”

“Yes. Now, I will imbue some of the mana into your body.”

“What should I do?”

“Nothing,” Javier replied. “Close your eyes and feel the mana coursing through your body as I control its movement.”

“Is it like energy transference?” Lloyd muttered a concept he picked up while he was reading fantasy stories.

“What is energy transference?” Javier asked.

“Nothing. Let’s get started,” Lloyd said.

“Yes.”

Lloyd then closed his eyes. He relaxed all of his body as the tension loosened. He felt Javier’s palm touching his back, and the rough and rigid texture caused Lloyd to think how coarse it was for an elegant, noble-looking person. Seconds later, cold and clear energy flowed into his body, starting from the back.

Whoosh…

So this is what mana feels like. It’s foreign yet amazing. The mana penetrated his skin and muscles. Like a dry cloth slowly absorbing water, the mana passed through his body down to his intestines and further down

to his navel. That's where the mana made a U-turn. Like an automobile making its way onto the highway, it entered the spine. It crept upward from one bone to another, stimulating the senses along the way. It traveled up to the back of his neck and to the tip of his head. Afterward, it spread downward, from his face down to his chest. It then started to wrap around his heart.

Thump! Thump!

Lloyd heard the clear rhythm of his pounding heart. The swollen muscles around the organ pulsed and contracted. It sucked and released blood in a steady and strong repetitive motion. A glob of mana seeped into the heart, following the organ's movement and flow. It came naturally into the center of his heart, spreading its energy to other parts of the body.

Lloyd's mind cleared. He remained still in that state of clarity and opened his eyes several seconds later.

"How was it?"

Javier's voice sounded clearer than before. There was more. The training hall, the clouds, and everything in front of him appeared more vivid than earlier. The world he perceived previously was in HD. But now, with mana-powered vision, the world appeared in 8K Ultra HD.

Even the wind felt different as it brushed against his skin. Lloyd's senses improved in all aspects just from one mana reaction session. He turned around and found Javier softly grinning at him. Lloyd grinned back.

It was his first mana reaction experience; and now, it was time for Lloyd to give Javier his honest feedback.

"It sucks," Lloyd concluded.

"Excuse me…?"

"It sucks," Lloyd said once again.

The satisfaction on Javier's face vanished right away.

But Lloyd didn’t care about his change of expression. He simply became more brazen and nonchalantly added, “I don’t feel much different.”

“Did you not feel the movement of mana in your body?” Javier inquired.

“Oh, I did.”

“Master Lloyd, that means you reacted to the mana. I am sure your senses became sharper than before,” Javier said in an almost defensive manner.

“Oh, come on. Are you telling me you deserve a pat on the back just for this?”

“Master Lloyd.”

Javier’s look grew serious, and there was irritation in his eyes. It was also reflected in his voice. “You cannot overlook and dismiss the change. It is what it is.”

“The mana reaction training is about this? That’s it?”

“Yes. I think you have been gravely mistaken,” Javier stated.

“Mistaken? What do you mean?”

“You had too many expectations.”

“For myself, you mean?” Lloyd spoke nonchalantly.

“Yes.” Javier’s tone sounded a bit irritated. “One session does not turn you into an outlandishly strong man or super-human. It’s rather the opposite. In order to develop a manaheart, it is of great importance that you take one step at a time,” Javier explained patiently. “You cannot expect the first spoonful of soup to fill your stomach. I am sure you know this since it is common sense.”

“Yeah, of course I do,” Lloyd replied.

“But then, why are you complaining?”

“Complaining? Me?”

“Yes. Are you feeling anxious as the day of the duel is coming near?” Javier asked. “To be honest, you barely stand a chance in the duel. It was an unfair contest in the first place. Sir Neumann is not a weak man. He is a knight who is on the path to being a proper sword expert.”

“Yeah, I know. I know that he’s a sword expert. Definitely not someone I can easily compete with, especially when I’m here just beginning basic mana reaction training.”

“Excuse me…?” Javier, who had been eloquently defending his case, stuttered for the first time.

Lloyd looked at him in the eyes meaningfully. “Do you think that I’m simply being ruthless and stubborn without any plans?” Lloyd asked.

“Well…”

“Come on. How long are you going to pretend you have no idea?”

“I still do not know what you are getting at.”

“Hey, Javier Asrahan. Why do you think I singularly picked you to teach me swordsmanship?” Lloyd inquired. “Did you really think of me as a dweeb who goes to challenge an experienced swordsman because fifteen days of mana training is what it takes to beat that old knight?”

“Um, well…”

“Let’s be honest, Javier. You got something more than this typical reinforcement method, don’t you? Something that you hide for yourself.” *I knew it.* Lloyd once again realized that Javier sucked at lying. *He’s just too obvious.* The thought made Lloyd laugh.

A chuckle escaped him. “Fine, I will be blunt. The Asrahan Core Technique. I want you to teach me that. And don’t even think of playing dumb this time.”

Javier’s eyes widened in disbelief.

In *The Knight of Blood and Iron*, the Asrahan Core Technique was the exceptional training method Javier developed that led him to become the first grandmaster in history.

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Chapter 13: The Asrahan Core Technique (2)

“The Asrahan Core Technique. I want you to teach me that. And don’t even think of playing dumb this time.”

Javier was stupefied. His eyes widened, and his mouth hung open in disbelief. It was only natural. To Javier, the person in front of him was nothing but an object of protection. And yet he uttered something Javier had never imagined even once.

Master Lloyd knows about my mana training? How? He couldn’t wrap his head around it. Just like when his master talked about his insomnia. But this mana training confounded him more. It was exclusive to himself, a secret he had never mentioned nor hinted of to anyone.

Plus, it had only been a month since he named the training ‘Asrahan Core Technique.’

How did he find this out? I haven’t even completed it yet… Javier wondered for a second if Lloyd had mastered the art of mind reading. In that flash of a second, Lloyd appeared like a mysterious and inexplicable being. Javier’s eyes reflected his emotions as he looked at his master.

Lloyd scoffed at the sight. “What? Why? What? Why are you squinting your eyes like that?” Lloyd demanded to know.

“Well, of course…”

“Of course, what?” Lloyd retorted.

“How did you find out about it?”

For the past few weeks, Lloyd had been exposing Javier’s innermost thoughts he only kept to himself. And each time Javier tried to deny them, Lloyd blatantly scoffed at and mocked him. Since Javier held enough of such experiences, he decided that he shouldn’t deny it anymore. But he wanted to find out how his young master saw through him like that.

Lloyd's answer was simple. "You said it all in your sleep," Lloyd stated coolly.

"Pardon?" Javier frowned.

"I'm telling you. You explained it to me while you were asleep," Lloyd reiterated.

"Are you telling the truth?"

"Uh-huh." Lloyd smiled brightly.

Telling the truth, my foot. It's obviously a lie. Javier never snored nor talked in his sleep. When he could sleep, he slept like a piece of fine sculpture, matching his elegant appearance.

But Lloyd decided to silence his protesting conscience and take the low road by lying. "Do you want me to prove it to you?" Lloyd offered.

"Prove? How?"

"Well, I'll tell you the details," Lloyd said. He began to recite the Asrahan Core Technique, as he had read it in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.*

"There is a limit to a human's manaheart. It's biological and determined from birth. So that means there's a limit to the amount one can mobilize at a go." The principle was simple. It was the same idea behind computer RAM or a water bucket. Eight gigabytes of RAM could store only eight gigabytes of data at a time and nothing more. In the same way, a one-liter bucket could contain only as much as it can, which is one liter of liquid. The same went for the amount of mana humans can use and mobilize within their hearts.

Its limit was the size of the heart. No human could go over the limit.

"There are no exceptions. Even the strongest swordsmen and knights who've achieved extraordinary feats. Why? It's simple," Lloyd explained confidently. "Because they're born human. A human body… no… specifically a human heart, can never overcome the biological limits it has.

That’s why dragons are such buff creatures in the stories. They have a dragon heart.”

“That is…”

“Shush. I’m not done yet.” Lloyd cut him short. “So, you thought to yourself. What if I can draw in the mana from the outside instead of sourcing it from my body? What would happen if I concentrated the mana absorbed from external sources into my manaheart? You wondered if you could temporarily overcome your biological limits and use more mana than you can handle.” Lloyd grinned after he finished.

Javier appeared calm and collected. But he couldn’t fool Lloyd, who caught the slight tremble in Javier’s eyes.

“And your questions led you to secretly research new ways to manipulate mana. And you gave a name to it. The Asrahan Core Technique. About a month ago… if I’m correct. Right?”

“Yes… you are correct,” Javier answered hesitantly.

“Hey, are you okay? You’re conceding awfully quickly today.”

“That is because you are so right about everything that I cannot even think of denying it.”

“As I thought, then let’s go back to where we left off.”

Lloyd figured that it was time to bring up what he really had in mind.

“First. How dare you? You had a sleek, amazing technique up your sleeve, and you dare try to teach me the simplest and most boring technique everyone knows how to use?” Lloyd raised his voice accusingly. “Did you used to teach preschool kids who were just happy with everything you do? How dare you try to bamboozle me like that.”

“But Master Lloyd…”

“I know.” Lloyd looked at Javier gravely. “This technique is yours, and you don’t give it out to strangers. But come on. I’m not a stranger to you, am I?”

“Yes, you are,” Javier answered resolutely.

“Dang.”

“Technically speaking, you are just the master I protect, and…”

“And…?” Anticipation clouded Lloyd’s face.

“And even if I wish to teach you my technique, it is impossible.”

“How so?”

“Because it is incomplete.” Javier’s voice grew solemn. “The concept you just explained is correct,” Javier went on. “The idea is that you absorb the mana from external sources, so you can use it. But no one has ever succeeded in this. I simply heard about the theory.” Javier shrugged. “I, for one, never succeeded.”

“So?” Lloyd asked.

“It is dangerous,” Javier explained matter-of-factly, “especially so for someone like you, Master Lloyd, who is taking baby steps in channeling mana.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“Are you saying that, because you are worried about me?”

“Of course not.”

“Tsk. So straightforward.”

“Thank you.”

“So, what you’re saying is you can’t teach me that because it’s dangerous, right?”

“Yes,” Javier answered.

“What if it were not dangerous?”

“Excuse me…?” There was a slight quiver in Javier’s eyebrows.

Lloyd chuckled. *He must be nervous about what I’m going to bring up this time.*

“Allow me to point out the part you’re stuck with, why it’s yet to be completed.”

“I don’t know what you are getting at…”

“You absorb the mana from outside, it works. You transfer it to your manaheart, and it works. But when you’re about to combine that with the mana that was already in your body… Bam!” Lloyd clapped his hands in exaggeration.

“That’s where you get stuck. You mix the two, but two different mana clash and bounce off. That’s the part you’re struggling with, right?” Lloyd said.

Javier’s eyes trembled. “How did you know that?”

“How else? I told you. I heard you talk in your sleep,” Lloyd reminded Javier. This lie—that Javier talked about in his sleep—worked perfectly to silence Javier and clear Lloyd from any suspicion. It was like a cheat code. The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose further up. *I bet he’s got nothing to say. I mean, how can he prove that he didn’t say it while he was completely out of it happily sleeping?*

Just then, Lloyd recalled the beginning of *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* At first, Javier wasn’t able to perfect the technique because of the mana collision. He tried out several other methods but failed each time. It took five more years until he came up with a new approach to complete the technique. Afterward, he worked even harder to polish the finished product.

And at last, he became the first grand master in the history of the Lorasian continent.

Lloyd remembered the approach that took Javier five years to find. With that in mind, Lloyd said, “From my perspective, I think it’s a mistake, not an error mind you, to combine the internal and external mana into one.”

“What?” Javier’s brow rose upward. “I’m not sure what you mean.”

“It’s just as I said. Why do you have to shove the external mana into the manaheart?” Lloyd inquired. “If you do that, it takes a toll on the heart because of the storage capacity of your manaheart. And why do you have to mix the two mana in the first place? Don’t you think you’re being a bit narrow-minded?”

“You mean…”

“You can always circulate the mana outside. Away from the manaheart,” Lloyd concluded, raising his hands in the air.

Javier’s eyes widened in utter shock.

This should be enough info for him to work with. Lloyd picked up a wood branch in the corner of the training hall. He then began to illustrate his point by drawing on the ground. “Look. You absorb the mana from outside, and… you rotate it this way. Around the heart and manaheart,” Lloyd explained as he drew a heart.

“Do you mean that I should create a mana circle and wrap the heart with it?” Javier inquired.

“That’s it. A circle. It’s a good name.” Lloyd confirmed.

“But what about the natural mana in your body…?”

“You don’t have to mix the two. You operate it separately. Your natural mana works inside your manaheart, while the other one will rotate your manaheart from the outside in a circular form. What do you think?”

“Hey, I’m just suggesting here. You know that I’m just a noob with this stuff. I guess I was just able to think outside the box,” Lloyd commented. “Well, you can always try it out if you’re doubtful.”

“I will.” Javier immediately nodded his head. It appeared that he understood what his young master meant. After that, Lloyd talked no more. He simply stepped aside and watched Javier test out the new method.

Sometime later…

Javier finally opened his eyes. And he turned and looked at Lloyd.

“Thank you.”

Ding Dong.

[Your approval rating with Javier Asrahan has increased by five points.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: -22]

[You have earned 90 RP by improving relationships with main characters.]

[Current RP: 187]

[Your relationship state with Javier Asrahan has been changed from hatred to awkward.]

[You have earned 5 RP as a bonus for the improvement.]

[Current RP: 192]

He did it.

He could tell from how Javier thanked him. And his gaze was a little bit different too. It was more adoring. Not only that, but the approval rating message proved that Javier succeeded.

“Did it go well?” Lloyd asked him nonetheless.

“Yes, Master Lloyd,” Javier replied.

“What about the circle?”

“It worked,” Javier answered, his voice sounding a little exhilarated. “But I created several circles because it seemed inefficient to utilize just one circle and focus all the absorbed mana there.”

“How many did you make?”

“Three.”

“Dang.”

First, he succeeds in separating the mana at the first attempt, and now he creates three circles in one go? Lloyd once again realized that Javier was a knight with enormous potential. *I guess it’s just a matter of time until he becomes a sword master.*

Currently, Javier was a high-level sword expert, so he still had a way to go before he could step up and move on to the next level. *But since he was able to create three circles around the manaheart, fighting a sword master shouldn’t take that much of a toll on him. If he’s lucky, the fight might end up in a draw.*

The advantage of using the Asrahan Core Technique was that it empowered the users to go beyond their current level. That was possible because it absorbed the mana from an external source to be added to the existing mana. Each circle was like a supplementary engine added to the main one.

Javier’s success reminded Lloyd of what happened in the novel. Javier completes the Asrahan Core Technique when he is a sword master. As soon as he perfects it, he creates four circles or the quadra-circles. That alone equips him with unrivaled power among his fellow sword masters. And when he rises as the grandmaster, he succeeds in creating penta-circles. In the final part of the epic, he achieves the extraordinary feat of hexa-circles. The story states that the amount of mana Javier uses in one motion far exceeds that of a dragon heart.

But of course, Javier was ignorant of all of this. He had no idea that he had just fast-forwarded the beginning of his epic story, the completion of the Asrahan Core Technique, by five years.

Lloyd was dazed, basking in joy to witness such a legendary moment up close. But he shook his head because it wasn't the time to be impressed. It didn't put food on his table. This was the time to seize any opportunities that would make him rich.

"You must be grateful to me, aren't you, Javier?" Lloyd said, his voice sounding meaningful and suggestive.

"Yes, Master Lloyd," Javier replied.

"I guess now you have a reason to teach me then."

"Pardon?" Javier frowned.

"The Asrahan Core Technique," Lloyd said as he took a step forward. "Eh? What's that attitude? Don't tell me that you're just going to thank me and turn around and leave."

"But Master Lloyd…"

"Yeah, what is it?"

"I believe that you should learn the basics first — how to reinforce and draw the mana — that is more important."

"Yeah, so?"

"So why don't you learn the basics first and my technique later?"

"Yeah… No." Lloyd flatly rejected the offer. That was mainly because the duel was happening in two weeks. He was in a hurry. "Try to put yourself in my shoes," Lloyd explained. "Do you think that this basic mana training would come in useful at a duel that's happening in fifteen days?"

"I do not think it will," Javier confessed.

“Right? So, I guess what you’re saying is that I should just lose the duel, right? I know. I know what you’re thinking right now, Javier. Look at the long-term. Immediate defeat wouldn’t harm me much. It’s better to master the basics,” Lloyd stated. “You’re not wrong about that. It really isn’t wrong. But to me, it is wrong.”

“How so?”

“Because this duel matters a lot to me.” Lloyd was telling the truth. Sir Neumann had already betrayed the baron behind everyone’s back. And Lloyd finally had the chance to make an example out of him and show everyone what happens to those who betray the barony.

But if he lost, that would be it for him. Everything would be a mess. He needed this fiefdom to stay wealthy and comfortable for the rest of his life.

“I must win, come hell or high water,” Lloyd stated, his voice brimming with determination. “And I’m going to learn the Asrahan Core Technique.”

“But what if I say no?” Javier asked.

“Oh, is that how you want to play this? Well, I have my ways then.” Lloyd smiled brightly.

He had a surefire offer that would get Javier to accept the deal.

“If you don’t teach me your technique, say goodbye to my lullaby service.”

“What? Why? What? Why are you looking at me like that? You think that’s a cheap shot?”

“A little bit,” Javier confessed.

“Well, there is no such thing as a free lunch. You can always teach me your technique if you feel wronged.”

Javier was deep in thought.

Lloyd flashed a meaningful smile. *You won't be able to reject the deal. I know because you've already tasted the bliss of peaceful uninterrupted sleep.*

For the past few days, Javier has been sleeping like a baby, thanks to Lloyd's recitation of the lectures he learned back when he was a civil engineering student. Lloyd was confident that Javier's heart sank when he announced the possible cancellation of the lullaby service. *We humans are like that. It sucks more when we've received something only for it to be taken away.*

This was a universal truth.

There was no going back after experiencing the convenience and comfort of certain objects and services provided. *People can't go back to using payphones because they know how convenient it is to use smartphones. It's the same with robot vacuums, height-boosting insoles, food delivery apps, social sharing sites, and elevators. The discomfort of living without them becomes too overwhelming to bear.*

Javier must be going through this right now. He had been suffering from insomnia for many years now, and he had just learned what it was like to rest well. There was no going back for him. Just as Lloyd expected, Javier nodded in affirmation.

"Whew… All right"

"All right, what?"

"I will teach you my Asrahan Core Technique."

"Good choice." Lloyd clenched his fists. *I knew it. All your sword skills will eventually be mine.*

The Asrahan Core Technique.

It was time to master it.

***

Time flew. The day of the duel was getting closer. Training never stopped for the entire time. Lloyd's basic stamina improved manyfold. He also focused on the Asrahan Core Technique.

Lloyd had commissioned a blacksmith to create a special weapon for him. "It has to be pure steel. Here's the design," Lloyd said as he held out the design to the blacksmith.

"Master Lloyd? what is this?"

"It's the design for my weapon. Why? Is it strange?"

"No, but how are you going to fight with this…?" the blacksmith muttered.

"No questions, please. Can you make it?"

"Eh? Y-yes."

"I'll leave you to it, then."

The blacksmith was dumbfounded when he received the design from Lloyd. He looked at it several times. It didn't look like a suitable weapon to be used in a fight. But what could he do? The blacksmith knew what Lloyd was like: the son of the feudal lord and the worst hooligan in the land. He wouldn't dare work up the courage to criticize Lloyd's request.

A few days later.

It was finally the day.

The duel was happening today.

"Young Master, the blacksmith delivered the weapon." The weapon Lloyd commissioned was delivered to the estate. As he heard the maid announce the delivery, Lloyd softly clenched his fists.

The Asrahan Core Technique. And my special weapon… Everything was all set.

Sir Neumann. You're so dead. Lloyd's eyes flashed with fierce determination.

At last, the day had come for him to trim a weed.

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Chapter 14: The Lunatic’s Four Weapons (1)

The early spring sun blessed the land with light. Everyone was finishing their morning chores. Farmers wiped their sweat off in the fields, while lumberjacks set down their axes and breathed in some fresh air. A shepherd’s flute filled the meadow with sweet melodies. Winemakers in their vineyards and laundry maids down by the river all paused their work for a while. Everything came to a halt at this hour, for it was time for lunch.

However, something was different today. Something extraordinary was taking place at the Frontera estate’s training center.

“Hey, what do you think will happen today in the duel?” a farmer asked his friend.

“What do you mean? It’s clear who’s going to win,” he replied.

“Are you thinking what I’m thinking?”

“Of course. Who else?” he said matter-of-factly.

“Right? How in the world could Sir Lloyd beat Sir Neumann?”

“We’ll all have fun, ha-ha. Oh, what fun we'll have to see them fight,” the guy said with a smile on his face.

“Hahaha, you’re not wrong,” another exclaimed. “I’m going to savor every moment the young master gets thrown to the ground with a face full of dirt. This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity.”

The farmers chattered with one another as they gathered in the corner of the training center. Beside them was a group of women who also skipped lunch for the duel.

“I’m a bit worried,” one of them said.

“Worried? How so?” another replied.

“I’m worried about the young master. What if he wins against Sir Neumann? That’s going to make him more of a jerk.”

“My, why would you worry about it? You’ve got nothing to worry about,” another replied as she waved her hands.

“How so? I heard that Master Lloyd whipped and smacked Sir Ulrich until he begged for mercy,” she countered.

“But we’re talking about Sir Neumann here.”

“Hmm… So, are you saying there’s no chance for Master Lloyd to win?”

“Certainly not. Sir Neumann is the strongest man in the fiefdom,” she boasted. “And who cares who wins? This kind of entertainment was just what we need to kill the boredom.”

Dozens of people gathered at the training center to watch the duel. Most of them anticipated that Lloyd Frontera would be the loser. They rooted for Sir Neumann. As far as they knew, their young master had never even held a sword before. Although he had calmed down a month or two ago, the Lloyd Frontera they knew was a man who lived in a drunken stupor. Aside from his drinking problem, the people cheered for Sir Neumann because of the troubles Lloyd had caused in the land. He was a bad example to the children of their land. Almost everyone was a victim of his unsightly behavior and harassment.

I pray to the heavens that Sir Neumann will put the fear of God into that man. That must be enough to teach him a lesson to stay low and keep things down. Please, please…!

Most of those gathered had the same wish. But there were a few who supported Lloyd.

“But you know, Master Lloyd has been staying out of trouble these days.” It was a shepherd boy who spoke. His voice sounded cautious. But his comment immediately attracted the annoyed voices of the woodcutters around him.

“Hey, kid. People don’t change,” one of them said defiantly.

“Sir, but it is true that he has changed,” the boy insisted.

“Sure. That’s true. But so what? It’s only been two months. He’s got to keep up that good behavior for a while to earn our trust,” the man huffed.

“But he installed the floor heating system, the ondol, in my house,” the boy cried.

“Tsk. Didn’t you pay for it?” the guy huffed again.

“But it’s very warm and nice,” the boy replied.

“Goodness. Whatever. You’re a boy crying wolf anyway.”

“I’m not lying. I’m telling the truth!”

“Enough,” the guy said solemnly. “I’ve signed the contract for that floor heating system or whatever, so I’ll find out soon. Let’s enjoy the show first.”

“Yes, sir…”

Other than the shepherd boy, few rooted for Lloyd.

The baron and the baroness were there in support of their son. Baron Frontera called Sir Neumann earlier in the day to ask a favor of him.

“Sir Neumann,” Baron Frontera called.

“Yes, My Lord.”

“Please take care of my son today.”

“Understood. Please do not worry about it.”

“Thank you,” the baron continued, “Though my son has acted impertinently, he is going to be your master in the future. So please don’t be

too harsh on him. Make sure he is free from injury."

"I will keep that in mind, sir."

In short, even those who rooted for him didn't believe that he would actually win. So not a single soul in the crowd thought victory would go to Lloyd. When Lloyd finally appeared in the arena, what little hope they had in their hearts vanished immediately. The result of the duel was already determined in their heads. Sir Neumann would win.

"I present to you, Sir Lloyd!" the estate servant shouted.

The announcement moved everyone to turn toward the entrance. And at last, Lloyd trudged into the training center. He was holding a shovel in his hand.

"Eh?" Everyone's eyes widened in surprise.

They saw the shovel. And they wondered for a second if they were on a construction site.

I thought he came here for a duel.

Why is he holding a shovel instead of a sword, an ax, or a spear? They wondered to themselves.

"Hey, is construction happening here after the fight?" one of the soldiers asked.

"What do you mean?" answered another.

"I mean, the floor heating system construction Sir Lloyd is obsessed with these days," he replied.

"Are you asking if it's happening here? No way."

"Right?"

"Yeah, no way."

The soldiers who weren't working today chatted with one another. They couldn’t wrap their brains around this. As everyone stared and wondered, Lloyd strolled into the center of the ring looking nonchalant. The bright sunlight revealed the shovel in his hand more clearly. Everyone could see that the shovel was made out of solid steel from top to bottom.

There was only one reason why Lloyd commissioned it that way. The shovel was a weapon, not a garden tool. Lloyd walked closer to the bleachers where the baron was sitting. He then spoke aloud. “I, Lloyd Frontera, the son of Arcos Frontera, is ready to face Sir Neumann in armed combat!”

It became crystal clear to everyone. He really was here to do this duel.

The baron furrowed his eyebrows.

“Are you prepared for this duel?” the baron asked.

“Yes,” Lloyd answered.

“What about your weapon? Where is your weapon?”

“Here,” Lloyd said as he smiled and lifted up the steel shovel. “This is my weapon.”

The baron was too shocked to respond. He had thought Lloyd was coming to his senses, but he was wrong. His hope for his eldest son to realize his mistakes and live a proper life was abjectly betrayed. *I can’t believe he has come to the duel with such a perfunctory attitude.*

The baron gritted his teeth. His heart sank with disappointment. With a sterner countenance, he gazed at Sir Neumann, and nodded slightly at him. *You can rough him up. Pull him back to his senses.*

Sir Neumann nodded at his master in response, understanding his look. *Yes, My Lord. At your service.*

This was just as he wanted. Things were developing exactly according to his wishes. Every fiber of his being yearned to roughen up the arrogant

young master and hammer some sense into him. And when he turned and saw the way the young master was standing, Sir Neumann became more eager to beat him down.

Chatter, chatter. The audience murmured in wonder.

Lloyd was striking a weird pose that no one had ever seen before. He was holding his shovel, with arms wide apart. His left hand clutched right below the shovel head. His right hand casually held the handle. He steadily bent his arms. This made him look like he was almost carrying the shovel in the air, and its sharp head pointed toward Sir Neumann. This posture looked ridiculously funny and awkward to Sir Neumann, who had never seen anything like it.

Unable to hold still any longer, Sir Neumann squeezed his nose. “Master Lloyd, may I remind you… We are meant to duel.”

“Yeah, I know that.”

“Then why are you standing like that?” Sir Neumann asked.

“Oh? I’m getting ready to fight,” Lloyd answered.

“Are you mocking me with your childish pranks?”

“Eh? No, I’m not.”

“Then what are you trying to do?” Sir Neumann demanded.

“Can’t you see? I’m getting ready to beat the crap out of you.”

“I see… I’ll make you regret those words.”

“Pshaw, whatever.”

Crack! Sir Neumann gritted his teeth.

Trying to hold back the rage surging in his heart for being so insulted, Sir Neumann looked at Baron Frontera and spoke. “I am ready to duel.”

Sir Neumann's announcement was solemn and stern. The audience swallowed nervously as they felt the iciness in his voice. They tensed up in anticipation of the duel and hoped it would live up to their expectations.

Finally, the baron declared, "I hereby announce the commencement of this fair contest between these two honorable gentlemen of the realm."

As soon as the official announcement was made, Sir Neumann revealed his fangs. He immediately charged toward Lloyd.

You little punk! I'll teach you a lesson! Whoosh! Sir Neumann's feet pushed lightly off the ground, sending his body charging forward. He was faster than an ordinary person.

Lloyd and Sir Neumann were standing at a four-yard distance before the fight began. But it took only one leap for Sir Neumann to close the gap.

"Wow…!" The audience exclaimed, impressed by his lightning speed.

Before the noise died down, Sir Neumann's sword moved. Still encased in its sheath, it slashed through the air. *I'll start by giving you one or two broken bones!*

Sir Neumann knew how to tame a wild horse. He beat the animal until it came to its senses and calmed down.

He was already sick and tired of this tacky province stuck in the middle of nowhere. He began hating this place a long time ago. That's why he decided to take advantage of this chance to crush the young master, who he deemed unworthy of his station.

I'm going to unleash the beast today! The baron won't hold me to blame. Afterward, I'll leave this place. Just as I promised! Bwahahahaha!!!

He pictured a rosy future for himself and his partner in crime. Others criticized him for being a real estate swindler. But Sir Neumann begged to differ. *His business was just! It's all fair game!* Sir Neumann had passed along information about the Frontera barony to his partner, who had used it

to usurp the baron’s assets. In return, Sir Neumann received a healthy kickback as payment.

There was more.

This business partner had offered that Sir Neumann should come to work for him and leave this good-for-nothing province. He promised better treatment befitting his prestigious knightly status.

Of course, he should! My talent is too precious to be wasted in the sticks!

Sir Neumann was an ambitious man with big dreams. He dreamed of rising to fame with his sword and living in riches. Now he was close to achieving that dream. But there were things to take care of first like the rude and impertinent young master he was about to drop some schooling on. Hard.

I’ll teach you a lesson!

Swoosh! The encased long sword swung in the air. The audience shuddered at the sight. He brandished the sword diagonally from right to left. His target was Lloyd’s left clavicle. *Let’s start with a collarbone!* Sir Neumann’s eyes gleamed with cruelty. He was resolute.

That upstart Lloyd would never be able to defend the incoming blow. It would be an impossibility for that dumb punk standing there stupidly with a shovel in his hand.

Everyone there thought exactly the same thing. Including Baron Frontera, who was watching the fight from behind his usual stern expression; and, the baroness, who had dug her nails into her palms in anxiety.

But there was one in the crowd that thought otherwise. It was Javier. *Master Lloyd was not joking when he assumed that position.* Narrowing his eyes to slits, Javier observed the fight, following every movement between the two. He considered Lloyd’s posture unusually awkward; but, at the same time, he looked stable and comfortable. That stance couldn’t have been mastered overnight. Such stable footing told Javier that Lloyd had struck such a pose many times before the duel.

He had never assumed that position while he practiced with me. Does this mean that he also trained separately without my knowing? Whatever the case was, one thing was for sure. *There's no mistaking it. This position was only created for the real fight.* Chills ran down his spine at the realization. He had a feeling that the duel might end up entirely different from what everyone expected. And a second later, Javier realized that he was right.

Swish! The steel shovel moved at last. It softly drew a vertical line in the air, blocking the incoming long sword.

Clatter! His motion was so simple that it looked easy.

Sir Neumann wasn't taken aback when his blow didn't land as expected.

Ha! Try blocking it all you want! He thought Lloyd had just gotten lucky. He fumbled to defend it like any other novice, and it worked. Pure luck and nothing else. Sir Neumann scoffed, remembering who he was. He was a knight that had reached expert swordsman level. He could use mana Lloyd would never be able to conjure.

I'll shatter your defenses with my strength!

*Flash! S*ir Neumann's eyes blazed with anger. His long sword glimmered softly. Mana flowed into his sword, covering its blade with a thin layer of mysterious energy.

But seconds later… The energy suddenly faded away.

To be precise, it was absorbed into the steel shovel. The mana was transferred from the sword into the shovel. The same happened in his body. The mana left Sir Neumann 's manaheart with a 'swoosh.'

Eh…? Sir Neumann's eyes flew wide open in astonishment.

At that moment, the shovel moved again. *Clang!* The sword was pushed to the side, like a fly being swatted away. Sir Neumann strove to endure the pressure on his sword, but he could not. He felt strange, like the power was leaving his body.

Sensing an opportunity, Lloyd swung his shovel very hard.

Thwack!

“Argh…!”

The shovel knocked Sir Neumann right in the face.

Drops of blood splattered out of his mouth, as the sheer force of the strike sent his head jerking to one side.

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Chapter 15: The Lunatic's Four Weapons (2)

Thwack!

A painful blow to the face.

"Oof!"

Sir Neumann's world just turned upside down.

What just happened? He was dazed at that moment. But it didn't last long. Sir Neumann quickly recovered himself and immediately figured out the predicament he was in. *Okay. He blocked my attack. And not only that, he struck back at me! Is this for real?*

Time seemed to have slowed down. He saw drops of blood flying slowly through the air. It was his blood, from his mouth. That's when he noticed the numbness. The strike must have busted up his mouth. *That punk did this to me?*

Crack! Sir Neumann found himself gritting his teeth again. He moved quickly, spreading his legs wide to get a stable footing. He lowered his back just in time to avoid falling to the ground.

"Ah-h-h!!" he shouted out loud, as soon as he regained balance. Then, he drew out mana from his manaheart. It spread all over his body. Feeling the energy coming back to him, he pulled his sword out and wielded it high.

His counterattack was immediately blocked again. *Kerrang!*

"Oh, would you look at that? You attack right away. I did the same to Sir Ulrich, and it completely knocked him out."

"Grrr…!"

The wide shovel head blocked the long sword. But Sir Neumann wasn't going to give up. He shifted his approach with the sword when he saw that

the attack didn’t work. He took a step forward and gave his sword a twist.

Brangg! The sword and shovel slammed together with a loud metallic crash.

Time to lose your shovel! Sir Neumann quickly devised a plan. He would press his sword hard against the shovel. Next, he’d rotate it twice and give a strong jerk to disarm Lloyd. Then, he would trip Lloyd and knock him to the ground.

He thought it was a surefire method to neutralize Lloyd.

But he failed to realize one important truth in life, and that was that everyone had a brilliant plan until they were destroyed.

“Tsk. Are you trying to disarm me? Nice try,” Lloyd said defiantly.

Clatter! Just as soon as Lloyd finished speaking, the sword and shovel froze in midair. Technically, it was Lloyd who willed the shovel to stop, which made the sword halt too. Then something else happened. The power in Sir Neumann’s manaheart started to get sucked out like the tide.

Neumann’s power flowed out from his manaheart, through his arms, and into his sword… And it streamed from the sword into the shovel just like soda pops up a drinking straw. Lloyd sucked up all that power like a dry sponge. Lloyd’s shovel was sucking the mana right out of Sir Neumann’s body.

“What is this?!” Terrified, Sir Neumann attempted to pull his sword back quickly. But he couldn’t separate it. Now drained of mana he found himself moving slower than usual. It was as if he had become an ordinary person at that moment.

As Sir Neumann was suffering, Lloyd pressed forward his attack with speed and skill that would normally be displayed only by a far more advanced fighter. “I am so relieved,” Lloyd muttered under his breath.

Zoom! With that, Lloyd easily narrowed his distance from Sir Neumann.

“You!!” Sir Neumann attempted to brandish his sword with the scabbard still on.

But Lloyd was faster. *Swoosh!*

Sir Neumann caught a glimpse of the shovel handle heading straight for his face. A second later he felt a searing pain in his nose. *Crack!*

“Ack!” Is my nose broken!*?* He wondered. He couldn’t open his eyes because of the searing pain. He staggered back three steps.

Lloyd didn’t stop there. He charged forth. The fire was in him now.

“I was a bit worried, actually,” Lloyd said nonchalantly. “I’ve never tested whether a single circle can take the mana of a swordsman at your level.”

“Arggh!” Sir Neumann shrieked and frantically swung his sword down to counterattack. He felt a small portion of his mana restored at that second. But Lloyd defended the attack with his shovel in a breeze, and despair clouded over Sir Neumann’s face again.

The tiny bit of mana left in the sword got sucked into the shovel once more!

This is nuts!

Wham! Lloyd swung his mana-charged shovel and slapped Sir Neumann in the face. It blinded him as his head jerked to one side. Such a thing had never happened before. Sir Neumann had never imagined that this was even possible in real life.

That punk is… absorbing my mana…

Sir Neumann was starting to understand what was happening. But that pitched him into much further dismay. *How can he absorb another person’s mana? And how can he use it as his own…? How???*

He felt cheated. This was unfair. But he was no quitter. Sir Neumann struggled to get back on his feet to continue the attack. But it was all in vain. The more he struggled, the more he became ensnared.

Must be confused, eh? I'm sure you can't wrap your head around this. That's why you're losing. You spent the last month goofing around, simply being overly confident that you were going to win. But I didn't! Lloyd thought to himself.

Over the past month, Lloyd carefully analyzed the opponent he was going up against. He predicted all the possibilities in the duel. He covered everything — from A to Z — to ensure that he would win. Now he was reaping the fruits of his labor.

Clang! Thwack! The shovel danced in his hands as he stood his ground at the edge of striking distance. He barely had to move to defend against the incoming blows from Sir Neumann's sword. Moving his left foot forward, Lloyd extended the shovel head. With a simple jerk of his wrist, he slapped Sir Neumann in the face with the back of the shovel.

Lloyd's heart pounded like it had never pounded before. Could this be from the mana circle forming around his heart?

Ziiing!

The first weapon Lloyd was equipped with for the duel was the mana circle, which he formed using the Asrahan Core Technique. The mana circle furiously rotated around his heart, fueled by his opponent's mana. The orbiting mana around his heart caused it to pump more violently, rushing fresh blood to all of his organs in an explosive manner. The blood combined with the mana that emanated from the circle.

So, this is the power of the single circle. It was truly amazing. Lloyd hadn't expected it to be this powerful. He imagined Sir Neumann would only be slightly weakened after absorbing his mana. But it did more than that. The power in his body far exceeded his expectations. It allowed Lloyd to use Sir Neumann's power without any difficulty.

Sword experts are amazing.

Lloyd felt like he had become superhuman. He realized how powerful knights like Sir Neumann are.

Clang! Clatter!

The second weapon Lloyd prepared was the steel shovel. His shovel looked like a shield attached to a javelin. *People may laugh at the weapon, but shovels are amazing tools.*

Anybody who used a shovel in the military knew how useful the tool was. It was more than useful.

If you found roots while digging, you just simply had to hold the shovel straight and scoop them up. One swing was enough to pluck small bushes and roots. It was like an ax in that sense.

There's more. Lloyd was aware that shovels were historically useful weapons in war. They were used in the gruesome trench warfare on the Western Front of World War I. Shovels were even widely used in the Battle of Stalingrad in World War II. They came in handy during hand-to-hand combat. One powerful swing was enough to slice a helmet in half and crack your opponent's skull.

Apart from these examples, shovels have a variety of other uses.

The shovel head can be used as a shield because of its width. You can lock the opponent's weapon with the base and pull it hard. The sharp point of the head can be used as a spear. And you know what happens if you hold it facing down and stand on the top of the shovel head? You can make it into a pogo stick!

The shovel was a truly versatile tool, and Lloyd was a master at handling one. It was his trustworthy companion as a junior enlisted soldier in the military. It was always there for him, even when he worked construction to pay for his tuition. That was how familiar he was with it.

And on top of that, he created new skills with the RP he recently amassed.

That was his third weapon.

The Tool Apprenticeship Skill: (Shovel), which he had spent a grand total of 40 RP to gain.

Ding dong!

[Tool Artisanship Skill: (Shovel) has been activated.]

The tool and I are one! Today is all about shoveling!

[Skill Level: 1]

[You use 10% less strength when using the shovel.]

[Shovel speed has increased by 5%.]

[Shovel power has increased by 5%.]

[Your chances of losing your grip on the shovel have decreased by 20%.]

The shovel was his go-to tool, and the skill he purchased with RP enabled him to use it more efficiently. This weapon was perfect for him.

And my fourth and last weapon is this.

Clang! Clatter!

Lloyd brandished his shovel again, impeccably parrying the thrusts of his opponent. The shovel never needed to move beyond Lloyd's center line. Each movement was simple, brief, and measured. It couldn't get any more efficient and practical.

Unbeknownst to everyone present at the scene, Lloyd was using a skill that went perfectly with the shovel. It was the bayonet exercises any military men and women would be familiar with.

Whoosh! Clang! Thwack! Crack!

Lloyd moved aside and stabbed toward the right. Sir Neumann retreated as he brandished his sword. Lloyd defended his lower half, and he engaged.

When Sir Neumann stepped back, Lloyd easily stepped forward. He swiveled to the left and held his shovel straight in defense. At the same time, he kicked Sir Neumann in the crotch. When he saw his opponent get flustered, he knocked him in the temple with the shovel handle.

Bam!

“Argh!” Sir Neumann staggered back.

Lloyd smiled, panting for air. *It’s working. The bayonet exercises.* Contrary to popular belief, these exercises weren’t useless.

They were believed to be useless because they had become so common in the military. But their origins date back to European short sword techniques from the 18th century. With that foundation, the old techniques were mixed with boxing steps. Eventually, after the two World Wars and the Korean War, the exercises were reborn with much more finesse.

So, in short, it actually was a practical combat exercise. *And you see, it goes perfectly with the shovel!*

Lloyd had seen whole battalions exercise with shovels. He was right there with them. He combined the basics of sword fighting he’d learned from Javier with it. The result was devastating.

The mana circle of the Asrahan Core Technique.

The ever-versatile steel shovel.

The construction site shoveling experience.

The practical bayonet exercises, mixed with Javier’s sword teaching.

These four powerful weapons Lloyd had prepared for the duel created a dynamic synergy. He wielded them in combination to unilaterally dominate and crush Sir Neumann, who had walked into the duel unprepared.

“Arggh!!”

Thwack! Sir Neumann staggered when the handle hit him in the temple. But he wasn't spared a second to fall down. Lloyd leaped forward and…

Thwack! He smacked Sir Neumann's side with the flat surface of the shovel. Then he

struck down at his feet with the pointed tip. *Smack!*

"Ack…!!!" Sir Neumann was beginning to lose it. He fought back, only to lose his mana again. The unpredictable attacks were unrelenting. Lloyd's maneuvers with the shovel felt too easy in his eyes. Each of his movements was clear-cut and precise, never giving time for a counterattack.

This is not happening! Anger surged in his heart. He blew a fuse. He was getting beaten by a rookie. And what's worse, he was getting crushed by someone who was using a shovel.

Most of the people in the fiefdom were gathered around to watch the fight.

I'm going to kill him. I'm going to kill him!!! Sir Neumann's eyes gleamed with dark bloodlust. He didn't give a damn whether this was a duel. This rookie who humiliated him in front of everyone had to be punished. He needed to end this son of a bitch by all means necessary.

Accidents happen during duels all the time! A simple thrust of the sword might pierce his heart. A random brandishing of the sword might slice his throat. It happened all the time. And even if such a thing were to happen in this duel, Sir Neumann was confident that he would be exonerated.

This fiefdom is going to go under soon anyway. I'm just going to leave this rathole earlier than scheduled! A new master, and I'll be living in riches! Who cares about a little dueling accident? What could I do? It's a duel, for pity's sake! They can't punish me!

His mind was set. After the duel, he'd disappear. He would leave and go find a new master. With the plan all set, Sir Neumann tightened his hand on the sword grip. Then, he placed his other hand on the scabbard. He pulled the sword out of its sheath.

Swish! The sharp blade of the long sword stood revealed. Without a second's hesitation, he charged toward Lloyd. The point of the sword aimed straight at his heart.

"Ahhh!!"

This attack was more menacing than the others, and it was intended to kill. The audience shrieked in surprise. Baron Frontera sprang to his feet.

But Lloyd stood calm. *Ha! So what if you pull your sword out?* He did feel the murderous vibe Sir Neumann gave off. But no matter, he thought to himself. His attack was laughably slow. And the many blows prior to this moment had sapped him of much energy. He may be carrying an extraordinary sword, but Lloyd was way too strong and agile to let this pathetic attack get him.

Lloyd had already anticipated that Sir Neumann would turn vicious. *I've been waiting for you to do this.*

Clatter! The steel shovel casually parried the attack. And the weapons were in a bind, just like Sir Neuman tried to do previously. *Clang! Clang!* The two weapons hit and pressed against each other. Lloyd suddenly tugged at and took the sword. He wrenched it away.

"Eh…?"

Swish! The long sword was hurled into the air. It dug into the ground ten steps away from them. Silence fell over the training center. Hundreds of people gazed at the sight in shock. Sir Neumann had lost his sword, and Lloyd was pointing the shovel at his face. It was clear as day who won, though the outcome was unbelievable.

Lloyd, however, wasn't done here.

"You think the battle is over just because you're beaten? Hmmm?"

Everyone's eyes slowly traced the shovel as it was lifted high in the air, and then descended at lightning speed to strike the face of Sir Neumann.

Thwack!

Was Lloyd attacking him again just to blow off some steam?

No, he wasn’t.

I’m just getting started now.

Lloyd was bent on removing the spoiled apple from the barrel. He was going to sever this problem at its roots.

First, I need this traitor to confess.

Lloyd’s eyes flashed with anger as he stared at Sir Neumann.

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Chapter 16: Setting an Example (1)

Sir Neumann. The senior knight of the Frontera barony. He hated this provincial fiefdom.

He wanted to succeed. He wanted to live in riches. To him, this was a vile cesspool.

The Frontera barony sat in a remote part of the kingdom. The idyllic scenery did not make up for it being on the outskirts of nowhere. Sir Neumann believed that enjoying the peace and tranquility of the countryside was suitable for retired old hags. This was not the place he belonged. He deserved more than being stuck here to rot.

I wanted to get out of here!

He wanted to go somewhere far from these lands. A bigger world was waiting for him, where he'd make his way to the top. He desired a life of luxury. To do that, he had to renounce his allegiance to Baron Frontera. But that was impossible.

He knew very well what happened to knights who swore off their allegiance to their master. They were ostracized wherever they went. No lord wished to take in that sort of knight. The stigma of being a dishonorable knight who betrayed their master would follow them for the rest of their lives.

So, he devised a plan. If he couldn't leave his lord and his dominion, he could bring about their ruin. Then his reputation would not be tarnished. He could leave this sickeningly tacky place without anyone pointing fingers at him.

He put his plan into action and made a deal with an outsider. He sold information about the baron and his estate. This led to the baron falling prey to an investment scam. When the financial burden on the baron became too much to bear, he reached out to loan sharks.

Sir Neumann was ecstatic. Soon the baron would go bankrupt. His freedom was near. *Everything was perfect. I just had to wait a little longer. So, why? Why am I getting thrashed by this garish twerp?*

Whip!

It was the sound of the shovel flying in his direction. The head of the shovel seemed to grow larger as he stared at it. Then rang a loud and crisp clanging noise, as his head was jerked violently off to one side. His skull rattled from the searing pain.

Thwack!

“Argh!!!” Sir Neumann’s legs lost all strength under him. Yet, he somehow barely managed to remain standing. Instead of fighting back, he pleaded in the most pitiful voice he could produce.

“S-stop! I do not hold my sword!” It was true. The sword had already left Sir Neumann long ago. He was unarmed. The victor of the duel was evident to all. It should have ended already by that point. That was the only proper thing to do. By the moral code Sir Neumann once followed, this was the proper procedure. It was just common sense. But Sir Neumann was right, he really had landed himself in a pool of shit.

Even though he was rendered weaponless, Lloyd didn’t stop attacking him. Lloyd simply lifted him back up and beat the hell out of him. Sir Neumann cried out in surrender several times, but Lloyd repeatedly turned a deaf ear and kept on beating him. Sir Neumann stumbled as he ran away, but Lloyd was hot on his heels, shovel in hand to hit him again and again.

“S-s-stop! Please, do not humiliate me any more!” yelled Sir Neumann, unable to hold it back any longer.

But Lloyd didn’t answer. Instead, he simply swung his shovel again.

Thwack!

“Argh!!” Neumann’s skull shook. *Someone… Please stop him…* The world around him was beginning to grow dark. He was afraid that he might actually die if it went on. And so, he realized that this wasn’t the time to guard his dignity. Eyes brimming with desperation, Sir Neumann looked at Baron Frontera. *My lord! Please help me!*

Sir Neumann knew that if there was anyone who could put a stop to the merciless thrashing from this son of a bitch, it was his father the baron. Sir Neumann turned frantically toward his master and collapsed. He lifted his head and stretched out one hand… *Please!*

At that moment, he forgot what he had done to the baron. He was a traitor. But when his life was at stake, he didn’t care about this betrayal. Fortune was on his side then, as the baron rose from his seat. “Lloyd, do stop now. It appears that the duel is over,” Baron Frontera said, his voice ringing loudly in the training center. His voice was low but carried the full weight of his authority as lord of these lands.

All thought then that Lloyd Frontera would stop his thrashing. The farmers, woodcutters, maids, and soldiers all thought the same. It was obvious. The order came from his father, the baron. Lloyd may often have his way, but this was an event of the state. The lord issued an order. No one imagined that Lloyd could ignore his father and continue this ferocious act of brutality.

But they were totally wrong.

Thwack!

The head of the shovel traced a clear arc through the afternoon sky, in a swing like that of a pro golfer at the first tee. It connected with the point of Sir Neuman’s chin with a clear and ringing crash.

“Ack…!”

“Ack, my foot,” Lloyd scoffed. “It’s not over yet. You deserve some more.”

Cough, cough! “Ack!” Sir Neumann coughed and sighed.

“Why? Why does it hurt? You think this is unfair? You think I’ve gone nuts? Is that it?” Lloyd asked.

“S-s-stop!”

“Stop?”

“Y-yes…”

“Who do you think you are to tell me what to do?”

Smack!

Lloyd struck Sir Neumann’s back with the shovel handle. Sir Neumann collapsed, crying in pain again. But Llyod’s expression was calm and composed. *You think this is unfair? There’s nothing you can do about it. I’m making an example out of you. If you didn’t want to end up this way, you shouldn’t have stabbed the baron in the back.* There wasn’t a single mistruth in his thoughts. It was a fact that the knight was a traitor. Going soft and forgiving him wouldn’t teach a lesson to him and everyone else. Would anyone believe he had repented and became a new person?

Never. Lloyd shook his head. Such stories existed only in fairytales. Lloyd knew too well how ugly the real world was. He had lived at the bottom of the social pyramid for way too long and he knew how people were.

I remember when I lived in a dorm. A man got caught after secretly stealing my food from the communal refrigerator. I should have lashed out at him. But instead, I got soft. But being nice wasn’t the right answer. At that time, he was so flustered that he missed the opportunity to say something. He simply laughed it off, nicely telling him to never do it again.

But what happened? *The guy kept stealing.* He even became more brazen after a while and reprimanded Lloyd for being so selfish. The world is all about sharing, the guy said. Lloyd just chuckled in disbelief. That dumbfounded feeling still chafed, even now.

How can I go soft on this traitor when the world is like that? Not a chance. People were nothing but shameless and selfish creatures who would happily sacrifice their morality over a small meal. Considering that, what would happen if he forgave this betrayer? What would happen if he extended mercy to this disgusting little traitor? *He'd take advantage of it.*

Lloyd was absolutely certain that would give birth to a gaggle of disgusting chicken hawks like Neumann who would join forces and try to ruin the barony.

"So, I'm going to make an example out of you," Lloyd announced solemnly. "That means I'm going to beat you up until you can't even blink your eyes. It's not over yet. So, stop talking gibberish and get up."

Lloyd had been waiting for this moment. He reached out his hand and grabbed Sir Neumann by the collar. With his other hand, Lloyd picked up his shovel.

"Did you not hear me when I ordered you to stop?!" The baron's scream echoed in the center.

Lloyd flinched and turned to the baron. He answered nonchalantly, "I heard it, sir." *Thwack!* He hit the middle of Sir Neumann's head as he answered.

The baron knitted his eyebrows. "What!?"

"I heard your order, but I can't follow it." *Thwack!* Lloyd smacked Sir Neumann once more.

The baron's face darkened. "Do you have any idea what you are doing right now?" the baron asked, his voice now high-pitched.

"Of course."

Wham!

Each time the shovel hit Sir Neumann; his body convulsed.

The baron's eyes gleamed with rage. "You are dishonoring your opponent," the baron patiently stated, "and what is more, you are mistreating a senior knight who has been serving our family for five generations."

"Yes," Lloyd answered. "And he's also a traitor who betrayed you and this estate after he received so much of your trust."

"What?" The baron flinched.

Lloyd responded coolly, "I knew you'd question me in disbelief. So, I came here prepared with proof. Please look under your tablecloth."

"What…"

"I've placed something for you under there," Lloyd directed.

The baron was dumbfounded. He wondered what his son meant. He couldn't believe that Sir Neumann would betray him. Though he was still too dazed to respond, he lifted the tablecloth as instructed. And his eyes widened in surprise. "This is…"

There was an envelope. He opened it. Several smudged papers were inside.

"What is this?" Baron Frontera asked.

"I will tell you once you are done reading it," Lloyd replied.

Baron Frontera had a bad feeling about this. His son's attitude was too confident for him to be messing around. He looked at the letters. He calmly started to read through them. Midway through, his fingers trembled, and he finished the rest in one quick skim.

"This is…"

Crumple! The baron clutched the letters. He glared fiercely at Sir Neumann in utter disbelief. His reaction wasn't surprising, given that the letters Lloyd delivered to the baron were the ones Sir Neumann had exchanged with the conman he had sold the information to about the workings of the estate.

Suddenly a name popped into his head. *Tordes.* He was a young merchant who had approached the baron. A passionate, discreet man with plenty of initiative. He came to the baron's estate one day and guaranteed on his honor that he came bearing good news. He said he knew of a great land investment, but it was worth nothing right now. He assured the baron that he should give it a few years; the value would increase manyfold.

Tordes promised that the baron would increase his assets in a few years if he purchased the land in advance. The baron trusted him, but he knew that every investment opportunity came with risks. Even if the investment went bad or rendered a smaller profit than he expected, he could just sell the land that he'd bought. He was at ease about the whole thing.

Since there was no reason to hesitate, he purchased the land using the estate's money as well as some that were loaned. And now… he had become penniless. *It turned out that the lands I'd purchased existed only on paper.* Of course he lost all of his investment.

Tordes, who had deceived him, went into hiding after taking the money. The baron found himself under crippling debt overnight. *And… the guy who leaked my preferences, interests, finances, and other personal information was… Sir Neumann?*

He remembered the many gifts he received from Tordes. From the mahogany furniture to a snow eagle collared shirt. Tordes showered him with gifts that he loved so much. Their topics of conversation were the same. Each time he conversed with Tordes, the subjects that arose were his favorite ones. He wondered how they were so perfectly compatible.

I thought he and I just clicked. And that's why I trusted him. The result of his trust was painful betrayal and bankruptcy. And Sir Neumann was responsible.

Thwack!

The baron felt his blood curdle. The pounding of his heart rang aloud in his ears. The world was getting hazy, and he suddenly became dizzy.

Lloyd smiled bitterly as he looked at the baron. *He must be shocked.* His closest associate turned out to be a traitor who was leading him to destruction. The shock and betrayal must be stinging. Even from a distance, Lloyd saw that the baron's face was as pale as a sheet. It wouldn't be strange for him to collapse. Lloyd wondered for a second if he had made the right choice by showing the letters to him.

But what else could I do? I needed hard proof for them to believe me. Ppodong the enchanted hamster was utilized for this purpose. He sent Ppodong into Sir Neumann's bedroom to find the letters. He knew the location of the letters from *The Knight of Blood and Iron*, which says that the correspondence between Sir Neumann and Tordes was stored in the bedside table drawer.

And it turned out to be true. So Ppodong infiltrated Sir Neumann's bedroom like a good little hamster. He was a small but strong animal, so it was a breeze for him to open the drawer. And that's how Lloyd was able to acquire the letters that incriminated the knight.

The letters contain the promise that Tordes would hire Sir Neumann in the future. It even has a charmed signature that proves the letter is real. That's why Sir Neumann couldn't throw it away. Thanks to that, I was able to get him.

Suddenly, Lloyd felt bitter about everything. He wished that the same thing would've happened in South Korea. Lloyd regretted that he hadn't left the evidence of the swindlers that deceived his father. That would have saved his family from falling on misfortune. His parents wouldn't have died like that at least.

Whew… Come on. Now's not the time to be sentimental. Lloyd shook his head. Now wasn't the time for it. He needed to make sure that this situation went to his advantage. Thinking that, Lloyd lifted his head. He spoke to the baron, whose face was still pale as a sheet. "Are you okay? If you are dizzy, please take a seat first and take a deep breath," Lloyd suggested.

"All… right…" The baron struggled to speak.

Witnessing the baron's reaction, Lloyd's initial impression that he didn't have the guts to be firm and stern was confirmed. He could only rule over the land with a good heart. Such a person could receive praise from people for being a saint when everything was well and peaceful. But it was a different story when the world was going through tough times. People took advantage of such good-hearted people. He would end up becoming a pushover and fall behind.

It's clear what the baron is like. Just look at him. Look how he just stands there in shock, not knowing what to do after finding out that his most trusted knight is a traitor.

Shock and chaos clouded the baron's expression. Until now, Sir Neumann was a trustworthy knight to him. The baron didn't know how he should take this betrayal, or how he should take care of it. That was why he was vacillating over his course of action and not being adamantly decisive right away.

*I'll do it for you, then. S*omeone had to do the job anyway. If the baron did nothing right now, his whole fiefdom would descend into chaos.

Lloyd began to speak, "I, Lloyd Frontera, the son of Arcos Frontera, have something to say as the rightful heir to this estate."

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Chapter 17: Setting an Example (2)

“I, Lloyd Frontera, the son of Arcos Frontera, have something to say as the rightful heir to this estate.”

Lloyd’s voice rang loudly in the hall. Everyone was staring hard at him. A farmer gulped nervously. A woodcutter found himself clenching his fist. A winemaker chewed on his lips. Nobody saw this coming. The defeat of the senior knight.

His opponent wasn’t even a proper knight. He was the baron’s son — a notoriously lazy drunken rogue — and yet he made mincemeat of the knight. That alone was shocking enough. But that wasn’t quite all of it. Lloyd kept assaulting the senior knight even after the duel ended.

The baron grew impatient at last and lashed out at his son to stop the cruelty.

Lloyd boldly responded to his father, announcing to everyone that this knight had betrayed the baron. Everyone was doubtful at first. But they saw how the baron’s face turned pale after he read the letters presented to him as evidence of the knight’s deceit. He slumped down on his chair as if his knees had buckled. Then he glared at Sir Neumann. His eyes welled in disappointment. That gave everyone a hint of the severity of what had happened.

Really? Is what the young master said true? They thought to themselves as they read the baron’s expression. Everyone waited in silence, wondering what would happen to Sir Neumann. All eyes were on Lloyd. They waited for him to speak.

Lloyd felt their stares. *Here comes the important part.* Before getting here, he had run several scenarios through his head. He organized all the details of the novel as much as his memory allowed. Afterward, he considered the status quo of the fiefdom and the relationships and emotions of the people. He predicted how the story could be changed by his actions. In short, he reached this point after carefully planning every detail. And surely, among

the many deliberations he had made, one of them included the baron's reaction. *It's going to backfire if I propose something too drastic.*

The baron was a good man with a soft heart. Even after tasting the bitter medicine of betrayal, he couldn't cut Sir Neumann out and punish him as he deserved. So, Lloyd thought that suggesting a harsh punishment for the traitor would only work in the scoundrel's favor.

In time he will take the bait. He understood his limits in this situation. He could only offer counsel and support, and that was it. The ball was in the baron's court. So, he needed to prime the baron to make sure that he would agree to whatever was suggested.

Lloyd cleared his throat. "I'm sure you are in a difficult spot. I am too. Sir Neumann holds a long history with our family, and he has done great things that he should be duly credited for."

"Hmm… Continue talking." The baron tilted his head in confusion, perhaps surprised to see his son cover for Sir Neumann instead of lashing out at him.

Lloyd continued to speak. "Surely, the actions revealed by today's duel are nothing short of shocking. He has turned his back on you and done great harm to the fiefdom."

"Are you suggesting that he has done good things we should be appreciative of and bad things that require our attention?" the baron asked.

"Yes," Lloyd answered. Thankfully, the conversation was going well. The baron was not a fool. He was simply a good man.

"So, do you mean that I must deal with him, considering everything he has done for us in the past?"

"Yes, that's right," replied Lloyd.

"Hmm… I am sensing that you have a punishment in mind."

“I sure do.” Lloyd let out a chuckle. And without a second of hesitation, he announced the punishment to the baron. “I am thinking of dropping a rat on his head,” Lloyd said calmly.

“A rat…?” the baron asked in confusion.

“Yes,” Lloyd answered and continued to explain. “I’m going to drop a rat on Sir Neumann’s head, and if he’s free from harm, let us spare him and give him a chance to atone for his mistakes.

“A chance to atone… What do you mean?” the baron inquired.

“I believe it would be fitting to demote him to an ordinary soldier.”

“Are you suggesting that he prove his repentance and loyalty by serving as an ordinary soldier?”

“Yes,” Lloyd answered.

The baron remained silent. The baroness found herself clutching her hands. Some of the audience started to turn to the side and chat among themselves. The sound of their indistinct murmurs and chattering were audible.

“Hey, what is he talking about?” a farmer asked a woodcutter beside him.

“I think he’s going to drop a rat,” the woodcutter replied.

“Right? You heard that too, right?”

“Yeah. Master Lloyd will drop a mouse on Sir Neumann’s head.”

“Could that be the punishment? That’s it?” the farmer asked.

“Uhm… I don’t know why, but maybe?” the woodcutter answered. The farmer shrugged his shoulders, and the woodcutter shook his head. They were baffled by the situation.

This time, one of the women spoke. “Who in the world would get hurt having a rat dropped on their head?”

“Uhm, I would,” another woman confessed.

“How?”

“I’m afraid of rats. It’s possible he would jump and scream and trip over something on the ground, getting hurt in the process,” she explained.

“But… it’s Sir Neumann we’re talking about.”

“So, he won’t be surprised,” she finally conceded.

“Of course,” the woman concluded.

The peasants chattered to themselves. They came up with several theories and racked their brains to imagine what could happen. But in the end, they concluded that dropping a rat on Sir Neumann’s head wouldn’t hurt him.

Therefore, everyone interpreted Lloyd’s suggestion the following way. “Master Lloyd is suggesting forgiving Sir Neumann. Don’t you think so, Javier?” Sir Bayern asked.

Javier, who was standing beside him, replied, “I think so too. It appears that the young master judges that such punishment is the most appropriate one.”

“Master Lloyd thinks so?”

“Yes, that’s right,” replied Javier. He paused for a second before continuing. “Sir Neumann has already been humiliated enough in front of everyone. And even if he is forgiven, that wouldn’t be the end of his disgrace.”

“You’re right,” Sir Bayern agreed, “He’ll be stripped of his knightly status and serve as an ordinary soldier.”

“Indeed. Nothing would be more disgraceful than that,” Javier said. “However…”

“What is it?” Sir Bayern asked.

“Something feels wrong here.”

“What do you mean?”

“What Master Lloyd suggested. Personally, I believe it’s a bit odd.”

Sir Bayern looked at Javier in confusion.

Javier searched for the best way to explain this. “It’s much too tame,” Javier finally said. “It’s exceedingly merciful of Master Lloyd — so much so, that it doesn’t sound like him. In my opinion, that kid, no… the young master isn’t the type of person to be merciful and mild.”

Javier was telling the truth. He had been protecting Lloyd Frontera, and he observed what a man he was and how he held grudges against people. *He’s cunning, extraordinarily so. Not to mention, he’s also meticulous, tenacious, and manipulative.* Javier didn’t consider Lloyd a bad person. But he didn’t consider him a good person either.

The man has a petty heart. He never did anything that would result in a loss for him. He was nothing but an unscrupulous manipulator. That was Javier’s recent assessment of Lloyd’s character. *How else could I judge him?*

The man had drastically changed out of the blue. His daily drunken tantrums had stopped. But they were replaced by extreme pettiness. He meticulously tracked the construction payments from the villagers, and if he discovered that someone paid less, he would rush out — even in the middle of dinner — to get it. *What’s more, he’s keeping a tight rein on me with that peculiar lullaby service of his.*

Every night Javier was serenaded with incomprehensible words that put him soundly to sleep. At first, he was happy as a clam. It felt like he owned the world because he could sleep well. But he soon realized that he was wrong. *I realized the service came at a high cost.*

That man threatened him several times a day. “*Teach me how to use the sword, or else no more lullaby service. You do know that you and I share the copyright for the Asrahan Core Technique, right? Say yes if you want to*

keep sleeping well at night. I'm a bit thirsty. You know what to do. Bring me a glass of water, and I'll extend the service by a day."

Words fell short of describing Lloyd's pettiness. Javier was in the palm of his hand. There was no way to escape. No, he didn't even have the courage to cut the snare by himself, because the lullabies that man provided were much too sweet.

Whew… I feel so pathetic every time I think about it. Anyway, there is simply no way that such a devious person would easily forgive Sir Neumann for betraying the fiefdom and challenging his authority. No way. That was possible when he was a drunk. But now? Not in a million years would he forgive the knight like that.

Javier was certain that Lloyd had something up his sleeve. The young master was hiding a vicious scheme. Javier narrowed his eyes and glared at Lloyd. He was the only person in the hall to doubt him. The others were utterly surprised by the unexpected magnanimity and benevolence Lloyd was showing to his enemy. Among them, Baron Frontera was the most astounded.

Yes. You've come up with a rather mild judgment, Lloyd. The baron nodded in approval. He didn't see this coming. He was pleased. *I thought my son would die a hooligan without any fear of the heavens.* But that wasn't the case. Looking back, he realized that he was wrong. His son was already a grown, mature man.

This is absolutely amazing. Now I get it. My dear son, you had it all figured out before the fight with Sir Neumann. You knew about his betrayal. That's why you picked a fight with Sir Neumann and challenged him to a duel. Everything Lloyd did was by design, and he wanted to punish Sir Neumann publicly and severely for a reason.

Yes. Your plan was to punish him and make it clear to everyone what fate awaited traitors. And by manifesting your generosity at a crucial moment such as now and shattering everyone's expectations, you will wisely win the hearts of the people. The baron's heart swelled with pride as he thought this.

Sir Neumann may have betrayed the fiefdom, but there was no denying that he was a valuable asset. *A knight of such caliber is hard to come by.* The baron knew that his lands sat in a remote area of the kingdom. Knights usually avoided coming down here. That was even more true for knights who were experts with a sword.

My son is setting the order right in the fiefdom by teaching a lesson to Sir Neumann. At the same time, he's also exhibiting generosity by giving the traitor a chance to repent and correct his faults. As such, the fiefdom is still able to keep the traitor's talent for its own use. Brilliant. Sir Neumann must have learned something from this, Baron Frontera told himself.

The baron was certain that the senior knight would be moved by the decision to forgive him. He would repent for his wrongdoings with genuine remorse, thus prompting him to be more loyal. The baron was overwhelmed. *I cannot believe my son came up with this plan. How thorough and wise.* The baron almost choked up in pride.

Suppressing the joy that surged in his heart, he nodded. "Okay, Lloyd. You may do as you please. Sir Neumann. What do you say to the offer Lloyd has suggested?"

"It's good…!" Sir Neumann, who was sprawled on the ground, immediately nodded several times. Though almost all his bodily functions were damaged because of the merciless beatings and thrashings, Sir Neumann's hearing was intact. And so, he was able to hear everything Lloyd proposed to the baron. Inside, Sir Neumann was throwing a party in joy.

He's just going to drop one rat over my head, and forgive me if I am not hurt? Why would I say no!? He would be forgiven, and the situation would be overlooked. Sir Neumann planned what he should do next. *Repentance, my ass! I won't let myself be demoted to a simple soldier. Not a chance.* Every fiber of his being rejected the idea.

I'm going to leave this sickening backwater right away. And then I shall exact my revenge.

Crack! He gritted his teeth, but not too loud for others to notice. He put on the most remorseful and contrite expression he could come up with. With an intentionally shaky voice, he said, “I shall prove it to you right now. I ask your baron to grant me the chance to accept the young master’s wise proposal.”

“Indeed.” The baron nodded. “Lloyd, do you have the rat you will drop on his head?”

“Yes,” Lloyd replied. “I came here with it.”

“Good. Do proceed,” the baron announced.

“Yes.”

Finally, the baron approved. The corners of Sir Neumann’s lip rose.

Lloyd had a vicious smile on his face.

“Hey, Sir Neumann. In a good mood? You’re smiling.” Lloyd pointed out.

“Pardon?” Sir Neumann asked.

“Well, fine. Congratulations. You think that you got the easy way out, right?”

“I am not… sure what you mean,” Sir Neumann said as he tilted his head. Now something felt wrong. Sir Neumann wondered why the young master was flashing such a happy smile. It also looked menacing.

“Oh, let me explain it to you.” Lloyd’s smile became even more vicious.

Just then, Sir Neumann noticed a small hamster in Lloyd’s hand. Lloyd was holding a red sunflower seed with his other hand.

No one except Sir Neumann saw this, as the others were all far away.

“There’s no easy way to beg for forgiveness.”

Sir Neuman replied bewilderingly… “Excuse me…?”

Crunch! The hamster chomped down on the red sunflower seed. A second later, Lloyd threw the animal high in the air and stepped well back.

And… *Leap!*

“Ppodong! Jump on him!!”

“Ppodong!”

A ginormous thirty-foot-tall hamster landed a belly flop right on top of Sir Neumann.

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Chapter 18: All Roads Lead to Rome (1)

“Ppodong!”

With that, Ppodong landed on his plump belly. Something that was between his belly and the ground cracked and crunched terribly.

Crunch! The walnut shell cracked. Ppodong smiled brightly as he removed the nuts from the crushed shell. “Ppodong? Ppo-do-dong. Ppodong.”

“Taste good?” Lloyd asked.

“Ppodong!” Then the hamster stuck the walnuts into his mouth at lightning speed.

Lloyd chuckled as he saw him do so. “Want another one?”

“Ppodong!”

“Want me to break the shells for you?”

“Ppodong? Ppo-do-dong!”

“Okay, hold on for a second.”

Lloyd grabbed the walnut with his right hand. Then he raised his left hand and used the Asrahan Core Technique. *Whew…* His heart was beating in time with his breathing. The beating pumped a flow of energy into his left hand. Lloyd absorbed the energy, which was natural mana floating in the air.

Oh, it works. Of course, the power wasn’t much. He could merely draw from a tiny portion of the mana floating in the air. He was just getting the hang of the Asrahan Core Technique, and could only create a single circle. But that was enough for him.

Swish! Lloyd transferred the power of the mana absorbed by his left hand to the outer part of his heart and rotated it. The mana was amplified as it

rotated. Once it was done, Lloyd transferred the mana to his other hand. He clenched his right fist to crush the walnut.

“Argh… Ackk!!” *Crack!* The hard walnut shell was crushed in his hand. *Whoa. It worked. I cracked the walnut with my bare hand.* This feat was unimaginable in the past. Basking in his success, Lloyd gave the walnut to Ppodong. “Here, take them.”

“Ppodong!”

“Are you happy?”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“Yes, me too.” Llyod felt that he was above the average man in physical ability now. He felt relieved by the realization. *This world is one of swords and knives.* Lloyd understood that he wasn’t in South Korea anymore. Dangers lingered everywhere. Just outside the fiefdom, bandits as big as pro wrestlers were happy to stab anyone in sight.

And so, he knew what his life would be like if he didn’t at least have basic self-defense skills. *I could die anytime. No, thank you.* Lloyd was relieved that he’d learned the Asrahan Core Technique from Javier.

Just then. *Knock knock.* There was someone at his bedroom door.

“Master Lloyd. Are you inside?” The voice was distinctively cynical in tone.

Javier. Lloyd chuckled. He rose from the bed and opened the door. Just as he expected, Javier was standing there. “Speak of the devil. Come on in.”

“Were you talking about me?” Javier asked.

“Don’t worry about it. So, did you do what I asked?”

“I’m coming from making the report to the lord.”

“Yeah?”

“Yes.”

“What did the baron say?”

“Are you asking if he mentioned anything special?”

“Yeah.”

“He did.”

“What did he say?” asked Lloyd.

“He wished Sir Neumann good luck.”

“Ha, he’s going to need it, especially right now,” stated Lloyd nonchalantly. *Sir Neumann.* Lloyd smirked as he thought about him. The events that had taken place in the past few days replayed in his head. The day of the duel when he exposed Sir Neumann to everybody. *He has luck on his side or maybe not this time.* Sir Neumann didn’t die. He was a tough, tenacious man who’d survived the crushing weight of the gigantic hamster Ppodong.

But the price of his survival was monumental. Dozens of broken bones throughout his entire body. The sight of him was a gory one. Everyone gasped as they found Sir Neumann looking much like a squid that had been sitting in a seafood market for a week. A doctor just shook his head in pity when confronted with Sir Neumann. *“The man is better off dead. Even if he receives the favor of the heavens and fully recovers, he won’t ever have a normal life. He won’t be able to walk or stand up. He will spend his entire life in bed, having someone feed him porridge that he can barely swallow.”*

The doctor’s diagnosis was hopeless for Sir Neumann. He had barely survived with the treatment he received in the past few days. And today, he was to be kicked out of the baron’s lands for good.

“Oh, well, he won’t die right away given that his family got banished along with him,” Lloyd said.

“I think so, too.”

Others were banished as well. Sir Ulrich and Conte, who mentored under Sir Neumann, were exiled. On top of that, they both had tendons slashed in a hand and leg. *They won't ever be able to pick up a sword again. I kind of feel bad for them. However, order has been established in the land. I have succeeded.*

The two were going to betray the fiefdom… according to the novel anyway. They would only continue to harm the barony. It was obvious they would never change no matter how many chances they received. So, Lloyd wanted to get rid of them as soon as possible. Today, he got what he wanted.

Lloyd felt good.

"So, you've become the vice commander of the knights now, Sir Asrahan? How are you feeling?" Lloyd asked with a smile.

"I do not feel anything in particular," Javier replied.

"Really?"

"Yes."

"How so?"

"Because I'm just one of two knights left, including Sir Bayern," Javier stated coolly.

"Hmm… You must be lonely then, I suppose? Tsk. I see. You are bored and lonely because you don't have any friends. That's what's happening," Lloyd concluded.

"That's obviously…"

"What's happening," Lloyd interrupted, "I know. Oh, well. What can you do? That's life."

"Master Lloyd."

“What?! Are you going to just glare at me? You have something to tell me?” Lloyd asked.

Unsurprisingly, Javier nodded. “Yes. I have a question to ask.”

“What is it?”

“It’s about the hamster.” Javier pointed at Ppodong, who was eating the pieces of walnut on top of the desk. Javier’s expression turned graver, and his focus sharpened.

Lloyd became slightly nervous at the sight. He wondered what Javier wanted to ask with such a dark expression on his face. *What is it? Is he suspicious of my summoning magic?* Lloyd suspected that it might be. It was fully plausible. *Right, although I purposefully carried the basic summoning book with me for a whole month, that wouldn’t be enough to clear me of all suspicion.* The thing was, summoning magic was still magic. So, unless he was born a genius, it made no sense that he could summon something with just a month of self-instruction.

Still, what else can I do? He’s not going to believe me, even if I tell him honestly about the RP system and the random summoning game. So, I might as well just insist on it. Lloyd decided that he should tell him that he had studied magic all by himself. Lloyd waited for Javier to ask.

Javier, who was waffling along with a serious expression, finally spoke. “What should I call him?”

“What…?” Lloyd asked in a daze.

“I’m curious what his name is.”

“Wait, are you asking for his name?”

“Yes.”

“That’s all you wanted to know?”

“Yes. It is your summon.”

“Oh, you mean you wanted to call him by his name because you’ll be seeing him a lot?” Lloyd asked again.

“Yes.”

“Then why did you act all serious about it?”

“Excuse me?” Javier looked innocently at Lloyd.

“Whew… Never mind. His name is Ppodong. That’s his name.”

“Ppodong?”

“Uh-huh.”

“Hmm… That is a bit of a shabby name with his gigantic size.”

“I named it myself.”

“Come to think of it, everyone knows a rubbish name is perfect for making your opponents put their guards down. You chose the best name for him.”

“Are you sure? You don’t have to lie when you don’t mean it. Anyway, I didn’t name it. It was his name from the beginning.”

“So, what should I call him…?”

“Anything you like.”

“I understand. Sir Ppodong?” Javier stooped down to greet Ppodong eye to eye.

Ppodong, who was chewing the walnut, lifted his head. “Ppodong?”

“My name is Javier Asrahan. I am the knight who protects Master Lloyd. Nice to meet you.”

“Ppodong!”

Javier’s long fingers interlocked with Ppodong’s short front legs to shake hands.

Lloyd yawned. “Done introducing each other?”

“Yes.”

“Shall we head out? I was actually waiting for you. I have some business to take care of,” Lloyd stated.

“Me?”

“Uh-huh. You’re my guard and way stronger than me.”

“That’s…”

“Forget it. Everyone tries to hide their true ability to some degree. Right?”

Javier flinched.

Lloyd chuckled. Javier was already an advanced swordsman. At first, Lloyd thought he simply failed to notice his true powers because that was how it was described in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* But after spending many days with this knight, Lloyd noticed something different from the novel.

The more time Lloyd spent with Javier — bickering with him and learning the ways of the sword — the more it became evident to Lloyd. Javier knew his skill level very well. He was simply hiding it. Lloyd hadn’t figured out the reason yet, but he could guess.

Everyone will go mental if they find out that the youngest knight is already close to becoming a sword master.

Sir Neumann and other high-ranked knights would be green with envy, not to mention the countless offers that would come from nearby feudal lords to bring him into their employ. Such aggravating efforts would surely leave the Frontera barony in tatters.

It's his way of preventing that chaos from happening and staying loyal to the baron. Lloyd thought highly of his knight, who had both skill and character.

"Anyway, let's head out. The sun will be setting soon." Lloyd sprang to his feet.

As expected, Javier looked relieved by that.

Lloyd figured that Javier didn't wish to continue talking about this subject. It was the same for him as well. *Your secret is safe with me. So don't bring up anything about my bayonet technique. Just keep any questions you might have to yourself.*

If there was a genius sword fighter, it was Javier. It only made sense that he would recognize the bayonet exercise, which held a long history. *I'm sure he noticed that I didn't invent the moves, since I'm just a novice.* The thing with martial arts and sports is that one sees only as far as one's knowledge goes, Lloyd thought to himself. Boxing and MMA were his best examples.

Boxing matches were an absolute bore to watch when he had no knowledge of the sport. MMA fights were even worse. The competitors did nothing but wrestle each other to the ground. When he started learning boxing and hapkido in high school and college, things started to change.

Boxing no longer put him to sleep.

MMA fighting used to just look like two people rolling around on the floor. Now it was an exciting battle that pumped his adrenaline.

Because people only look for what they know.

It went without saying that for Javier, a truly unique sword-fighting genius, it would be the same. He had, of course, already figured out most of the characteristics of the bayonet exercise. *Yeah, I can't avoid everything. Stay quiet, and I'll do the same for you. But don't do anything more than that.* Lloyd looked at him meaningfully. It seemed like Javier understood him.

Javier quietly stood up. “Let us go. I will escort you.” Thus, he and Javier left the bedroom. They left the mansion grounds, meeting several people as they walked. And Lloyd noticed a change in their reactions. They used to turn back and scurry away as soon as they met him on the street. They hung their heads low, because they were scared to look him in the eyes.

But that wasn’t the case anymore. A woman smiled and greeted him. She was the one who trembled in front of him on the first day he possessed Lloyd’s body. She wasn’t alone. Later, another farmer walked over to him and asked him with a smile, “Young master, excuse me. When can you start putting floor heating in my house?”

“Hmm?”

Lloyd recognized him. The farmer’s eyes were glimmering right now, but when he first met him, he was pale as snow. Lloyd rubbed his chin and said, “I can’t remember very well. Where was your house?”

“It’s left at the rock that stands at the entrance of the oak tree woods,” the farmer replied.

“Oh, there. Let’s see. Hmmm. Looks like you have two more houses ahead of yours.”

“So, when can I expect you to start…?”

“At this rate, probably around two more weeks, so wait a little longer. It’s springtime anyway.”

“But the wind is still cold,” the farmer explained.

“Okay, do you want me to hug you? Maybe that will warm you up.”

“N-no, that’s not it.”

“Don’t like that, do you? Good. I hate it too. I’m getting goosebumps,” Lloyd replied.

“Anyway, I'll be in your care, young master.”

“All right, and don’t forget to pay,” Lloyd reminded him.

“Of course.”

“Okay. Now, can you let go of my hands?” Lloyd resumed walking after tearing the farmer away from him. *Whew… I feel so popular these days.* The villagers started to see him in a different light. *Look at them. Just look at their beady little eyes. It’s like I’ve become a player who carries the whole game till victory, and my teammates are rooting for me.*

Suddenly, a bitter smile escaped him. Lloyd knew why they were looking at him like that. But still, he wanted to hear it from someone else. “Hey.” He casually called to Javier beside him. “What’s the deal with them? They used to hate me so visibly before.”

“Well, that was true in the past,” Javier explained.

“Was…? In the past?”

“Yes.”

“Then what about now?”

Javier replied as though he was reading a text. “It’s the birth of a capable man.”

“A capable man?”

“You defeated the senior knight with just a month of training. It would obviously appear impressive since they don’t know about the Asrahan Core Technique. Plus, you exposed his schemes to the public and did the summoning magic that shocked everyone in the audience.”

“Hmm… It does sound kind of cool when you say it like that. In short, I’m a truly amazing person who’s well-versed in sword fighting and magic, right?”

“Yes.” Javier nodded.

“If you think in their shoes, you will easily see why they welcome your change with open arms. You became a completely different person. From a good-for-nothing drunkard, who caused trouble daily, to an unbelievably accomplished man.

Lloyd was speechless.

“Their future leader has become a talented, skillful individual; no longer a hopeless scumbag. Surely you understand why they cheer over your change,” Javier concluded.

“Hey, that’s a compliment, right?” Lloyd asked suspiciously.

“Yes, it is.”

“You know, it’s quite weighty for a compliment.”

“What do you mean by that?”

“Your words came at me with a speed of at least 105mph,” Lloyd added.

“105mph?”

“Oh, come on. It means that my heart exploded from your compliment. You killer.”

Javier simply stared at him. His expression showed confusion over the nonsense he’d just heard.

But Lloyd noticed how even his dazed countenance resembled a beautiful painting that required untold hours to finish: elegant and perfect. *Must be nice to be good-looking. This bastard is a good fighter. Well-mannered and on top of everything. Handsome too.* Lloyd suddenly spoke like he was talking to his mother’s friend’s son, who he had never met but was constantly compared to. “What are you looking at? Move. Let me work.”

“Work?”

“From here to there.” Lloyd pointed at the ground with his fingers. He was pointing from the estate entrance to the foot of the eastern mountain. Lloyd was using his surveying and design skills as he looked at the area. He observed the geography and gathered data points. He visualized a blueprint of the building he wished to make.

The imaginary representation of the building allowed him a glimpse of the future of this area.

“All roads lead to Rome. This is the first time you heard about it, right?” Lloyd grinned, looking back at Javier. Of course, Javier didn’t know the meaning behind that smile.

He also didn’t know that this area would be used to build a paved road on that would become key to the territory’s development and that, in the future, it would lead the barony to become the primary travel hub for the kingdom.

That was until Lloyd spoke. When he listened to his young master, Javier caught a brief glimpse of their bright future.

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Chapter 19: All Roads Lead to Rome (2)

All roads lead to Rome. Anyone would have heard that saying at least once in their life. The expression was coined in Ancient Rome, where countless roads were built that stretched out to the ends of the empire.

Making roads was almost an obsession in the Roman Empire.

The Romans adhered to a strict set of construction principles. The roads had to be built in straight lines wherever possible. The roads connected all corners of their vast domain. They did not avoid drilling through mountains or building bridges over valleys. The Romans built fifty thousand miles of stone-paved roads. That was enough to circle the equator twice.

“That’s how important a road is. Do you know what’s the biggest factor that affects land value?” Lloyd asked.

“I don’t know,” Javier replied.

“Transportation. It’s transportation.”

Lloyd continued to speak while Javier remained silent. “Let’s say you have a house, and the road to the market from your house is very rough. There are mountains and streams to cross, and then you have bungee jumping to do as well. Every time you try to leave your house your body begs you to just stay inside. Would you want to live there?”

“I think it would be a great training opportunity.”

Lloyd was speechless.

“Hiking and swimming every day would certainly improve my endurance. The bungee jump… I do not know what that is, but if it pushes me to my limits, I am sure it would be a boon to my sword training,” Javier explained.

“I’m not talking about sword fanatics like you. I mean normal people.”

“Hmm… Then that would be a problem.”

“Right?” Lloyd beamed.

“Yes.”

“Now we’re talking.” The corners of Lloyd’s mouth rose in satisfaction.

“It’s not just the house. The fiefdom is the same. Care to guess what our biggest problem is?”

“In the past, you were the problem,” Javier answered coldly. “I am not so sure now.”

Lloyd cleared his throat. “The road. It’s the road.”

“The road?”

“Yes. Have you seen any properly paved roads in this estate?”

“No,” Javier answered.

“Right? That’s the problem.”

It was true. Not a single road in the Frontera barony was paved. There were only dirt paths that developed naturally on the bare grass patches of frequently traveled routes. Lloyd thought the time had come for this to change. His goal wasn’t just to create conventional roads. He aimed to utilize them for a greater goal.

“But you don’t need to know now what I plan on doing. So, can you move? I’ve got surveying to do,” Lloyd huffed. When it came to road construction, the result mattered more than the reason. Lloyd believed he should act rather than explain right now. He waved Javier away and studied the topography of the land.

Asphalt would be the best option, but it won’t happen here. Considering the technology available, I think the construction of Rome’s Via Appia is the best model we’ve got.

Lloyd recalled the Appian Way from when he was in the university. He had even done a class presentation about it.

The Appian Way was one of the earliest stone roads in Rome. Dozens more were constructed afterward. It greatly aided in the empire's conquest of the southern Italian Peninsula. The road remains strong and is still in use today.

The Appian Way boasted more than 2,300 years of history. Yet not a single inch needed any upgrading. It provides a window into civil engineering's advances in ancient Rome. Lloyd intended to build his own Appian Way through the central section of his estate.

From here to there.

Specifically, it would extend from the baron's estate to the far eastern mountain — cutting across the fiefdom in a straight line. It had the potential to become the main road once the fiefdom expanded in the future. The plan was perfect. But for him to achieve it, he needed to survey and design first.

First, I need to level up my skills. Lloyd opened his skill window.

Ding Dong.

[Loading the skill log.]

[Basic Surveying: Level 2]

[Basic Design: Level 2]

[Tool Artisanship Skill (Shovel): Level 1]

Hmm… It's just as I thought. I need to invest more in my surveying and design skills. For the past few months, he had surveyed and designed several heated flooring systems, and those skills improved by one point each time. But that wasn't enough for road construction.

I can only survey fourteen square yards at this skill level. And as for design, it's just 1,740 cubic yards of volume. That won't be enough. It's too

inefficient. Lloyd furrowed his brow. His design and survey skills were not good enough. A few days ago, he tested out how long his body would hold up before giving away to exhaustion. The result was not satisfying.

Each skill had a limit of ten uses. After that, he suffered from terrible fatigue and dizziness. Of course, the skill got canceled on its own as well. Making things worse, he needed almost a full day of recovery to use the skill again. In other words, he could survey 1,447 square yards of land and 17,408 cubic yards of volume in a day.

That is a problem, considering how far the mountain is from here. I need to hurry if I want to finish construction before the spring monsoon arrives. He didn't have much time. But fortunately, he had saved up a lot of RP.

[Current RP: 659]

He had saved quite a lot.

My, my, I feel like I should bow to Sir Neumann in gratitude. The duel with Sir Neumann made him rich with RP.

His approval rating increased manyfold. Twenty points each from the baron and baroness. Two points from Javier. One from Sir Bayern. And six from the people of the fiefdom. Thanks to that, he earned a big sum of 507 RP in a single day. But Lloyd didn't squander the points, because he knew they would be useful someday.

With that thought in mind, he had been frugal with his spending up until this moment. But now was the time to use the RP. *Let's see. I'll level up each skill to see what happens.* Lloyd looked at one side of the skill window. There was a level-up button. He blinked at it twice as if he was clicking a mouse.

Ding Dong.

[Log of skills you can level up]

[Basic Surveying: Level 2→ 3 (Required RP: 10)]

[Basic Design: Level 2 → 3 (Required RP: 10)]

[Tool Artisanship Skill (Shovel): Level 1 → 2 (Required RP: 15)]

I'll start with the surveying and design. He chose those two skills.

Ding Dong.

[Skill Level Up!]

[Basic Surveying: Level 3]

[Area that can be measured at once: 172 yd^2]

[Required RP to level up: 15]

[Basic Design: Level 3]

[Volume of structure that can be projected at once: 2,067 yd^3]

[Required RP to level up: 15]

[Current RP: 639]

Lloyd noticed a slight increase in his skill level, but he wasn't happy yet. *Might as well go all out while I'm at it.* Surveying and designing were the very skills that would put food on the table. Being cheap with them would only harm him in the long run. He boldly used the rest of his RP to level up those skills.

The surveying and design skills leveled on and on.

From level three to four…

Then level five to six…

Eventually, he reached level ten.

When he used the RP that last time to level up, a message appeared.

Ding Dong.

[Skill Class Level Up!]

[Your skill class has reached <Intermediate>.]

[Skills options have been made available following your change of skill class.]

[Intermediate Surveying: Level 1]

[Area that can be measured at once: 1,900 yd^2]

[Skill Option 1: Land Appraisal—You can appraise the land you measure. (Error rate: +/- 5%)]

[Skill Option 2: Underground Scanning—You can automatically scan the measured geography as deep as 16 feet. Geographical composition, soil quality, bedrock, underground water, reserved resources, etc., can be identified.]

[Required RP to level up: 100]

[Your skill class has reached <Intermediate>.]

[Skills options have been made available following your change of skill class.]

[Intermediate Design: Level 1]

[Volume of structure that can be projected at once: 83,700 yd^3]

[Skill Option 1: Plan Print—You can accurately print out your design on a designated surface such as paper.

[Skill Option 2: Floor Plan Indication (2D)—You can see the 2D floor plan of your designed output in the actual land. (Note: Only you can see it.)]

[Required RP to level up: 100]

[Current RP: 119]

Woah. This is amazing. Lloyd's eyes widened as he processed the changes. He had invested quite a lot of RP, but that barely mattered to him.

The potential survey area and design volume significantly increased. But there is something even more amazing than that. Lloyd looked at the skill options that were now available as the level of his basic skills went over ten. These options were seriously amazing.

Appraisal? Now that I can see the current price of land, this is no different from a real estate app. And underground scanning? For real? Lloyd decided to put this to the test. He looked at the ground and activated his intermediate-level skills.

Measure.

Crackle! A hazy ray of blue light filled his eyes. At the same time, the landscape changed in front of him. He scanned the square area of 130 feet in length and width. Several data points about the lot popped up. First was the estimated price.

Woah… I had no idea our lands were so worthless. The area Lloyd was scanning was a fairly developed one. There were several shops and taverns. The place was a metropolis in its own way. But for each ten square foot lot the selling price hardly reached one piece of gold!

Tsk. I guess I should work harder to bump up the price.

That was when it really dawned on Lloyd how small and rural the Frontera barony was. But that was all going to change further down the road. The land value would naturally go up if he kept improving things.

Lloyd turned his focus on other information collected with his new surveying skill. Underground scanning revealed many things.

Hey, this is way more useful than I expected. It was just as it said in the skill description. He could see sixteen feet underground. He saw the way the tree

roots spread through the soil and how the underground water flowed. He even saw rabbit burrows dug here and there.

Lloyd gulped unconsciously. *This… is glorious.*

Until today, his survey skills only rendered information about the ground's surface for him. What was beneath the ground could only be known after the land was excavated. But now that hassle was resolved in one swoop.

It's going to be super helpful when I'm laying the ground for any construction work. Foundations were crucial in construction. Its importance was amplified when the scale of the job grew. For example, if the workers did a poor job of laying the foundation of bridges or dams, the consequences were obvious. Whatever was built would tilt to one side, or its foundation would quickly crack and crumble. And finally, the entire structure would collapse. In some cases, the construction companies had to demolish the whole thing before disaster unfolded. It didn't matter how much money was used up to that point. The spending only doubled from there if you had to tear everything down to prevent further damage.

But that can be prevented by scanning the ground right from the beginning. The construction time would be greatly reduced as well. He would be able to inspect the groundwork in real-time, drastically shortening the construction period. And he'd be able to save money as well.

This design skill option is really something else. Lloyd looked at the two options in the design skill. *Printing out the plan and seeing the floor plan…* He wanted to put them to use, but Javier was right beside him. He could casually use his design skill, but that would seriously make Javier mistake him for a human blueprint printer.

I'll use the design skill when I'm alone. First up, surveying. *Crackle!* After that day, Lloyd engrossed himself in surveying the land during the day. He calculated the area of the road and surveyed the route. Over the next few days, he processed the data he collected. And he used the design skill with the assembled data. So, during the day, he surveyed the land, while at night, he focused on the design.

Each night, he rushed to put Javier to sleep.

“A plastic limit (PL) is defined as the percentage of water content when kneaded soil is rolled into a thread of 3.2mm (1/8”) in diameter. The PL… is soil… blah blah blah… and it’s the same case when the liquid limit is determined… blah blah blah… in case the cylindrical cone with the weight of 240g is used… the moisture content that responds to the entrance of the cone that is the size of d = 20mm is… blah blah blah…”

Snore…

When Javier drifted off, Lloyd could activate his design skills as much as he wanted. He designed the route and the cross-section of the roads based on the information he gathered from surveying. He gathered the floor plans as quietly as possible to not wake his sleeping friend Javier.

Be-beep! He tested printing the plan out on paper. Then, like magic, the floor plan was printed just the way he designed it.

Wow. It works. It really works! Up until today, he had to directly draw the floor plans he had designed by hand. It was unpleasant and tedious work. The accuracy dropped a bit too. But now, things were breezy and convenient. The plan got printed out like he would have drawn it.

The power of the skill options didn’t stop there.

One morning, a few days later, Lloyd tested the design skill as he stood in the construction area. He pointed to the area that would be turned into a road as he looked at Javier.

“Hey, Javier. Do you see that?”

“Excuse me? What do you mean?”

“There. Don’t you see the lines drawn all over the ground?” Lloyd asked.

“I don’t see them. But…” Javier muttered.

“But?”

“I am a bit worried about your eyes and… mental health.” Javier’s look was filled with concern.

“Are you saying that I’m seeing things?”

“Yes,” Javier answered.

“Baa ha-ha. I see.” Lloyd let out a wicked laugh. It was just as he expected. He had come out here the night before to draw the two-dimensional plan on several areas. But it was visible only to him and no one else.

Everything’s set. I can do it.

His surveying and design skills had improved much more than he anticipated. Thanks to that, the preparation was completed in a breeze.

Now, it was time to dive into full-scale construction work.

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Chapter 20: All Roads Lead to Rome (3)

Construction took off at full tilt. With Lloyd's improved surveying and design skills, the first part was completed in a breeze.

"Hey, Ppodong?" called Lloyd.

"Ppodong?"

"I will draw a line on the ground now. You see?"

"Ppodong!"

"Could you dig a five-foot-deep hole within the lines for me?"

"Ppo-do-dong!" Ppodong nodded his chubby head while resting it on Lloyd's hand.

"Great. First, eat this."

"Ppodong!"

Lloyd held out a red sunflower seed. Ppodong chewed it up like he couldn't wait for it. *Boom!* Within seconds, he grew to become a thirty-foot-tall giant hamster. Lloyd picked up his shovel and drew a straight line with it. He was following the line of the 2D floor plan that was only visible to him.

Swishhh!

"Okay, starting from here… In this direction. Right along the line, not an inch off. Everything must be forty-two feet wide," Lloyd instructed.

"Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!"

Swish! Swish! Swish! Ppodong deftly dug the ground up with his front paws. Each time his plump butt moved, a massive amount of sand flew behind him. Lloyd was impressed. Ppodong was no different than a high-capacity forklift.

Afterward, Lloyd ordered, “Civil engineers, group one. In now.”

“Yes!”

The group of engineers was composed of thirty soldiers. Each one carried a shovel, and they all moved together in formation. They jumped into the hole Ppodong dug out for them, and they shoveled the rocks, branches, and other small items out.

Clang! Clatter! Clash! Thwack! Pwash!

Thirty shovels dug up the ground at once. It was almost like a dance. The beads of sweat on their faces shone in the sunlight. As they worked, the sides and bottoms of the holes flattened beautifully. After that, Ppodong squashed the ground flat once again with his weight.

“Ppodong!”

Crush! His stout bottom squashed the soil like a stamp pressed onto a sheet of paper. All twenty-five tons of him pressed the earth down hard. He curled up and rolled around to compress the ground. *Swoosh!* Lloyd thought that Ppodong was nothing short of a big hamster construction roller.

While the basic construction work was underway, the second group of civil engineers moved diligently. This group transferred the fine sand from the river. Once they finished that, the first group transferred the sand to the hole, and the compacting job would continue. The engineers compacted the ground by patting it down with their shovels and Ppodong pressed the earth down further with his butt, making sure that the depth of the sand layer was fifteen inches.

This process ran in repeated cycles. *Dig, cover, pat, and press.*

Then the sand layer was covered with egg-sized pebbles, adding a layer a further fifteen inches deep. On top of that were tiny stones of the same thickness. Afterward, walnut-sized pieces of gravel carpeted the stone layer. Finally, it was covered with a seven-inch-thick layer of fine sand.

Sixty civil engineers, stonecutters, and miners put their noses to the grindstone. The tasks were efficiently assigned. They had enough time for rest and meals to get recharged. By the time everyone called it a day, about a hundred square feet had been completed.

“Good.” Lloyd smiled in satisfaction. They were making more progress than he expected. *It’s all thanks to Ppodong. Seriously, heavy machinery is a necessity in construction.* Ppodong acted as a forklift and roller, speeding up the entire construction process. Aside from the hamster, the soldiers’ contribution could not be overstated. They worked their asses off.

The training they got from the heated floor project is finally paying off. The sixty engineers were becoming masters of shoveling. Their stamina had also improved considerably. *All that labor built up their physique.*

Lloyd suddenly recalled the days he slaved away as a soldier in the Korean army. He joined the military to protect his country. But reality was much different than what he imagined. Once he was deployed to a base, he found himself protecting the company barracks and facilities in his line of duty, instead of protecting the country. His life in the military was full of nothing but various menial jobs and construction projects. It was far from military training.

There were all sorts of projects to do every day. He cut the grass and repaired the fences and plumbing. He repaired broken roofs and patched cracked walls. He set up a plastic shed behind the barracks and expanded the warehouse. *All just because I majored in civil engineering.*

He was like a genie to his superior officers… offering free construction services… *Tsk. It’s giving me the chills.* Remembering those days, Lloyd looked at the civil engineer soldiers, and he flashed a vicious grin. *All of you will know what I went through.*

He didn’t care the least about them. After all, these soldiers had been hired by the fiefdom to protect the place. He only needed to pay them a little more as an incentive, and that was it. No more complaints would be voiced. They were exactly what Lloyd needed: workers he could shovel into endless hours of labor at little cost.

The construction was still in its initial phase. He had a long way to go, and come hell or high water he was resolved to finish the first section of the paved road before the spring rains came.

***

A few days passed. Thankfully, the weather was clear. So, construction took off without any hassles. The work area stretched on and on every day. In the process, townspeople flooded in to see the roadwork and watch the project unfold.

“Woah, what is going on here?” A man asked as he passed by. “What’s all this fuss for?”

“Hey, haven’t you heard?”

“Heard what?”

“I heard this is called a paved road.”

“A paved road?”

“Yeah.”

“What’s it for?”

“I don’t know. But I heard it’s good.”

“Good? For what?”

“Who knows… It must be good for… well, something.”

“Well, I guess you’re just as ignorant as I am.”

“Phew.”

Others shook their heads and whispered among themselves. Seeing the road being built through the center of the land, many wondered what its purpose would be.

“Maybe it’s going to be a canal.”

“Not really, it looks like he’s going to pour water in there and freeze it to make an ice-skating rink.”

“No, you’re all wrong. That’s a field for crops. He’s going to stretch it up over yonder, so it’d be easy to harvest.”

“I’m not so sure about that… It’d be more convincing if you told me that he’s digging up the ground to play dominos.”

“Oh, come on! It’s a waterway!”

“Nah. It’s a skating rink.”

“Seriously, it’s a field.”

“I say that it’s a track for the runners to race on.”

Of course these people weren’t really so stupid that they didn’t notice what Lloyd was building. And they knew very well the purpose of paving a road. A paved road would make traveling much easier. It was also good for wagons that carried supplies. Which was exactly why people couldn’t understand. *Trade and travel don’t happen often enough here to need a new road… So, what’s happening…?*

People wondered why the young master was hell-bent on paving this new road. No one could wrap their head around it. This whole project appeared abruptly and seemed unnecessary. Sure, the old road turned muddy sometimes, but that was a minor inconvenience. So, it was a wonder to everyone why the construction was even taking place. The money, hours, and people put in there… ‘Was it worth it?’ they asked themselves.

But they weren’t alone. The soldiers digging things up felt the same way.

“Ugh! Whew… This is tough. Way too tough.”

“Hey, no goofing around. It’s not like you’re having it harder than anyone else.”

“I know that, but still. Hey, don’t you think this is a bit much?”

“What is?”

“Us. Being civil engineers. Sure, we get incentives the others don’t receive. But think about it. Don’t you think we’re just wasting our time and energy right now?”

“Wasting?”

“Stop and think about it. What’s the point of paving the road like this?”

“Um, well…”

“Nothing comes to mind, right?”

“You… are right…” The guy just scratched his head.

The complaining soldier wiped the sweat dripping from his brow. “That’s what I’m talking about. What do we have in this tiny fiefdom? It’s not like we’re trading with other lands. And there aren’t any armed forces or foreign delegations visiting us.”

“True, and we’re located far, far east in the kingdom.”

“Right? There’s nothing beyond here. It’s just us. No other kingdoms. Just mountains and barren lands.”

“Hmm, now that you put it that way, I see what you mean.”

“Now we’re talking. So what’s the point of working our butts off to pave a huge road? And did you notice that we’re building toward the east when nothing’s there?”

“What?! Are you sure?”

“Yeah, I am. See for yourself.”

“Shoot… You’re right…”

“Right?”

“Whew. But what can we do? The young master says jump, and we say how high.”

“You’re right about that. Tsk!”

Thwack! Thwack! Thwack! Their shoveling became more aggravated. The soldiers had been going through the same painstaking routine for several days straight. They were starting to ask themselves what all this was for. But the construction continued regardless of what doubts they harbored in their hearts. After all, it had already started.

Lloyd wasn’t ignorant of all this. He was already aware of what was grumbling in their hearts. But he didn’t care. He had no plans of quitting. He had a clear goal to achieve.

Everyone must be doubting and complaining right now. But just wait until it’s done… Once the construction was over, things would be different. They would be enlightened as to his grand plan. He was confident of that, so he decided to save his breath. He simply needed to show them the results.

And so, construction continued without any sign of stopping, reflecting his resolve.

They dug. They covered the holes with gravel and sand. They compressed and flattened the surface. Each day, more area was paved. The road reached from the center of the fiefdom to the foot of the mountain in the east. Afterward, they climbed the low slope, then the mountain foot, and worked on the mountain’s flank. When the construction reached that level, Lloyd decided that he should take it up a notch. It was time to get some serious paving done. Lloyd mobilized every mason in the estate.

“Okay. Your job is crucial from here on out. Everything that we did was for this very job. It’s time to pave the road for real,” he announced.

“Yes, young master.”

“Listen carefully. You should pave the road with stones by…”

Lloyd explained how the job must be done. The masons’ eyes glimmered with interest as they heard about the new construction technique. And with that, the paving project kicked off.

“Okay then! Let’s move! Don’t forget to comply with the safety guidelines!” Lloyd instructed.

“Yes, sir!”

The masons and soldiers were stationed in groups. They uniformly laid the road using large, flat stones composed of various materials. Each side of the stone was about two feet long. They were pieced together on the ground like a puzzle. Each piece fit so perfectly that there was barely any space between them.

There was more.

The center of the twenty-foot-wide road was built slightly higher than its edges. This was to create an arch, so that when it rained, the water would flow down the road on both sides instead of pooling in the center. The sides of the raised road had one-and-a-half-foot wide by half-foot deep drainage ditches. On the sides of the ditches were ten-foot-wide sidewalks.

This way, the roads won’t become submerged in water. The ditches on each side will naturally take care of the water, and the gravel, sand, and stones beneath the road will prevent the water from pooling. Finally, the sidewalks will separate the carriage and foot traffic.

As one last touch, Lloyd designated no-tree-planting zones on both sides of the road. He knew that tree roots might reach into the road’s foundation and make them uneven.

The construction took off again. The road expanded day by day. From the entrance of the baron’s estate to the residential areas. From the residential areas and market to the outskirts of the fiefdom. And then, from the outskirts to halfway up the eastern mountain. There, the construction ended.

For the first time in its history, a paved road that cut across the Frontera barony was established. But people could not understand exactly what the road was for. The people, the engineers, and even Baron Frontera who authorized it… No one knew. They were all in the dark about why Lloyd built the road.

These questions lingered in their heads, but time passed to welcome the spring rain. It rained hard for more than ten days. All the old roads turned muddy. Only the newly paved road was fine. This was not surprising. People saw this coming already. They had taken so much time to pave the road. So, it was obvious the road would remain in good condition even in the rain.

Although everyone had expected this, the doubt in them still lingered. They asked themselves why the young master created this luxurious road and wondered about its purpose. They started to have more questions as it rained harder.

On the morning the sky cleared up, Lloyd walked along the paved road. He climbed halfway up the mountain in the east. There, to everyone's surprise, he planted a construction notice.

Bituminous Coal Construction. No Farming Without Permission. Lloyd Frontera.

The grand plan Lloyd had imagined from the first day he was forced into this world was now slowly coming into existence.

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Chapter 21: Second Random Summon Game (1)

Clang! Clang! The sound of the shovel rang out clearly. The blade shone in the spring sunlight every time it moved. The shovel pounded the notice down with the metal clanking loudly. *Clang!* The sign was planted deep into the earth at last. Lloyd wiped off the sweat flowing down his forehead. “Whew.”

A warm breeze quickly dried the beads of sweat. The sunshine put him in a good mood. And the sign in front of him made him grin.

“Hey, what do you think?” Lloyd turned around as he spoke. He looked at the silver-haired knight standing behind him.

Javier, the silver-haired knight, threw a cynical look at Lloyd. “What do you mean by that?” he asked.

“Well, this.” Lloyd pointed at the notice. Javier looked at it. It was a wooden plank that had the following words painted large on it.

Bituminous Coal Construction Here: No Farming Without Permission. Lloyd Frontera.

“Notices like these need to be installed in advance. Otherwise, things get complicated,” Lloyd explained.

“How so?”

“They’ll turn this place into a field of peppers and cabbages and whatnot.” Lloyd smiled bitterly.

“I mean the old and young women alike. They’re so industrious in their farm work that they’ll rush to plant all sorts of veggies when they chance upon good land. Can you imagine what would happen if the land was originally meant for construction?”

It was a frequent occurrence in South Korea. When people did this, it would be bulldozed over by the construction companies. And penalties would be imposed on those who used the land without permission. It was a pitiful thing. Lloyd had no plans to make people go through the same thing here.

“Can you imagine what would happen if I plowed over the fields to build something?” Lloyd wondered. “People would bludgeon me for destroying their land. Some would even say that I’m a tyrant. And the good public image I’ve worked hard to build would go away like a dragon soaring high in the sky. Goodbye forever.”

“In short… You would be faced with severe criticism.”

“Yeah, that’s what I mean.” Lloyd brightly smiled. He had been receiving quite a lot of trust from people these days. And he wasn’t going to lose it over a tiny dispute.

“Anyway, the construction will begin soon. I’ll dig the land here to turn it into a mine, so we can extract coal.”

“By that, do you mean coal, sir?” Javier asked.

“Yeah, exactly. You know about it?”

“A little bit.”

Javier nodded his head.

“Coal is a small rock that is formed underground. I heard it is a great source of fire but much softer than firewood.”

“Yup, correct. That’s what we’ll be mining here.”

“Do you mean that coal is buried down here?” Javier asked.

“Yes.” Lloyd chuckled. “I found a record that claimed the previous lords tried twice to construct a mine but failed. The mine collapsed because the ground was weak.” Lloyd knew because he had read it in *the Knight of Blood and Iron*, and he had just remembered it.

Arcos Frontera.

In the novel, Lloyd's father killed himself when crushing debt became too much of a burden. Right before his unfortunate death, he cried his heart out about how today's tragedy could have been avoided had his father, Mattias Frontera, succeeded in building the mine.

That part of the novel was as clear as day in his head. Ever since then, he decided to develop these lands. He counted this mine as one of the most important parts of his agenda. But he didn't forget to check the site for himself, and his intermediate skills greatly helped him. The surveying skill allowed him to scan as deep as ten feet beneath the ground. He could study its rock formation, underground waterway, and body of ore.

Although, it would be nice if I could see deeper. He decided this place was the best option after scanning several viable candidates. That's why he laid out the paved road near here. Transferring coal from the mine would be a breeze. "Coal mining will become our golden goose for the time being. It's going to be the most efficient method to solve the firewood shortage that will surely come this winter."

"Firewood shortage?"

"Yes. Firewood will be in serious shortage because of the heated floors I'm installing. I'm not guessing here. It's bound to happen. I'm sure."

Lloyd shrugged and continued explaining. "That's the way it is with the heated floors. They warm you up. But, you need a lot of firewood since you're heating up the floor of the entire house, not just the kitchen or a small area like with a furnace. This could use up all the resources in the forest! In other words, the mountain will become bare in a few years."

"Because people cut down too many trees for firewood?"

"Yes."

"Then…"

“Did I see it coming? Of course, I did.” Lloyd’s smile became slightly more sinister.

“You know me. I designed the heated flooring system. Of course I saw this coming. By the time we’re in mid-winter, everyone will start to feel that the firewood in their backyard isn’t enough.”

“Then you deceived everyone?”

“Me?”

“Yes.” Javier’s voice was cold.

“They replaced their furnaces with your system because they trusted you. But if the firewood runs short, they will be spending half the winter shivering in the cold.”

“You are correct.”

“You cheated them.”

“No, not really.”

“Then…”

“I will be selling coal.”

“To the people here?”

“Totally. Coal is superior to wood. They’ll be begging me to sell it to them.” That was Lloyd’s plan. Stage one was to supply the heated flooring system to people. As more people installed it in their homes, firewood would run short. They would start to notice a flaw in the floor, its huge consumption of firewood. That was when he would sell them the coal he had been hoarding.

And I’ll expand my business to neighboring fiefdoms, eventually exporting coal to them as well.

Heated floors. Coal. These two would become the cash cows that contributed to paying off the fiefdom’s debt. The mere thought raised the corners of his mouth further.

On the other hand, Javier’s expression turned grim. “Please do not tell me that you had planned all this when you began.”

“Yes.”

“Since when?”

“Since day one. Since we visited the bar owner to apologize and got the first contract. If you have something to say, say it. Don’t look at me like that.”

“May I?”

“Go ahead.”

Javier did not hold back. “You are a wicked man.”

“Well, that’s better than being naive.”

“I hate that about you.”

“Me?”

“Yes.”

“You’re forgetting something.”

“What do you mean?”

“The person you hate sends you to dreamland every night. So, do you hate my lullaby service too? Ha-ha. You don’t have to think so hard. Look at you, just sweating over it. It’s so obvious. You stare into space like that, right after what I said. Open your eyes, man. I won’t tease you anymore. Relieved now, huh. So cute.”

“I…”

“Leave it. I’ll continue singing my lullabies to you every night, so don’t fret like a puppy.”

I’m not a puppy!!! Javier almost shouted back at his young master.

Before those words had the chance of slipping out of Javier’s mouth, Lloyd spoke first. “Well, I get why you’re reacting that way. You think that I’m fooling and using everyone for my benefit and you find that side of me deceitful. I know. I won’t deny it. But what else can I do? I need to save our fiefdom before anything else.”

The vicious smile on Lloyd’s face turned slightly bitter.

“You know what? Honestly, I thought that money wasn’t everything when I was young. But I realized that I was mistaken when I grew up. Nothing beats money. It turned out to be way better than my childish thoughts could ever fathom.”

“Master Lloyd…”

“Yeah, yeah. Money can’t buy happiness. But you can be happier if you have money. So, allow me to be underhanded and cunning for a while until I make some money. Let’s try to start paying off the debt in the fiefdom, okay?”

Javier closed his mouth. The sense of disgust that swirled in his heart vanished as soon as he heard Lloyd’s plan. His young master was calling himself a cheat and laughing about it. Though he didn’t say it out loud, his look seemed to say, *I’m going to bear all the blame. The criticism. The finger-pointing… I’ll take them alone, so don’t say anything. Just follow me.*

This guy… He was nothing but a good-for-nothing hooligan. But recently he had surprised Javier from time to time. The same thing was happening now. But Javier didn’t dislike it.

His methods are dubious, but…

In the many experiences Javier had with his young master, Lloyd was right most of the time. Lloyd had helped him finish the Asrahan Core Technique. He had exposed Sir Neumann. And so, Javier considered that it was possible that his young master was laying the foundation for projects that would advance the fiefdom further.

“Yes.” Javier found himself chuckling. “I will permit you.” He spoke from his heart. *Master Lloyd…* Javier gazed meaningfully at his young master, the person he must guard and protect.

Lloyd returned the look and cocked his head to one side. “Permit me? Wait, you’re permitting my plan?”

“Yes.”

“I think you’re confused right now.”

“Pardon?”

“I never asked for your permission.”

“You see… I’m the baron’s son. I don’t need your permission to dig a mine… So, enough with your misunderstandings, and move aside. I need to do some surveying.”

Javier’s elegant face crumpled. Lloyd chuckled out loud like a naughty child. *Oh, how fun. Javier. You’re so fun to tease.*

***

Ever since that day, Lloyd confined himself to the mine construction site. He surveyed the surroundings and analyzed the environment. There had been two previous attempts to dig a mine. Both of them had failed. Lloyd studied those cases and planned his own construction.

The traditional method of drilling through the rocks won’t work. It takes too much time, and more than that, it’s too dangerous.

As luck would have it, he discovered records of the failed construction attempts in his estate study. He went over them and found out they had tried to drill the rocks to construct a mine.

Splitting the rocks to pieces by heating and cooling them off and going deeper and deeper…

That was the traditional method of doing things back then. When the workers hit a large rock, they set fire to it. And then they poured cold water on it. The sudden change in temperature created a crack, making the rock easier for them to break into pieces.

That's how they did it at first. But they dug 100 feet. The mine collapsed. Twice.

And unfortunately, everyone in the mine lost their lives. That's why his grandfather, Mattias Frontera, gave up on his plan of building the mine.

What happened back then is simple. The place collapsed because of the weak ground.

Accidents were bound to happen if you failed to properly understand the geographical characteristics. After further surveying, Lloyd learned that the earth on this mountain was weak, containing a mix of rock and soil. He needed to employ a technique specific to this environment.

"I am thinking of using the shield method," Lloyd announced.

"Shield method?"

This was at dinner time. Lloyd slid a slip of paper toward the baron from his seat at the dining table.

"I have been thinking about it, and if you look here, you'll see a concept illustration of the shield method."

"Shield method…"

The baron looked at the illustration.

Lloyd continued to explain. “To put it simply, a shield refers to a large circular frame made of steel. The workers would get inside there and dig out the soil and rocks. The shield would protect the place from crumbling down as it will bear the pressure of the mine.”

“Hmm,” the baron mused, “it literally is a shield that supports the whole area.”

“Yes. Have you ever heard of shipworms?”

“Ship… worms?”

“Yes.”

“Do explain.”

“It’s a distant relative of a squid or snail. The little guy is quite harmful because of how it eats up ship hulls and burrows holes in them,” Lloyd explained.

“What does it have to do with this construction project?”

“This fellow is what inspired me to come up with the shield method,” Lloyd said. He smiled. It was true. In the mid-1800s, the Thames Tunnel was constructed in the following way, right beneath the River Thames in London, England. Marc Isambard Brunel, who constructed the Thames Tunnel, developed this method after drawing inspiration from shipworms.

“Shipworms burrow holes in the bottom of boats with their shield-like shell. But the wood expands when it gets soaked in water. That narrows the hole they burrowed, leading some of them to get squeezed to death. To prevent that, they paste their secretions as they burrow a hole. The secretions prevent the wood from expanding. The same goes for this shield method.” Lloyd pointed at the illustration and continued to explain.

“The shield acts as the shell of the shipworms. It protects the workers. And it would burrow a hole at the forefront. People will be divided into groups.

Some will dig, while some will install real-time facilities that will prevent the mine from collapsing.”

“Just like how the shipworm's secretions prevent the holes from being damaged?” asked the baron.

“Yes.”

“So, the whole process will be slow and steady. Burrowing and repairing all at the same time.”

“That is almost perfectly correct.”

Lloyd then explained more details of the construction while the baron remained still, listening to his son. The baron was intrigued. Coal was an excellent source of fire. Digging it up would naturally translate to profit. Under the pressure of crippling debt, the baron couldn’t help but be intrigued. And what was more, Lloyd’s plan sounded feasible and plausible.

At last, the baron approved the construction. “This is great, but I have one condition.”

“What is it?”

“I do not want you in the mine while the construction is happening.”

“Because it could be dangerous?” Lloyd asked.

“Of course,” the baron said. His voice was firm.

“I know this is a new method, but we cannot guarantee its safety.”

“But I can’t promise you that.”

“How so?”

“If I don’t go in,” Lloyd reasoned, “no workers would trust my method and do the work. Moreover, I need to actively observe any changes in the mine’s condition or surroundings. That’s the only way I can prevent accidents.”

“But…”

“It will be safe. I give you my word.”

“Hahaha.”

The two went back and forth. But Lloyd was the stubborn one. In the end, the baron gave in to his stubbornness and approved the construction of the mine.

But Lloyd didn’t get to it right away. He had another task to tackle first. He waited for night to come. When it did, he put Javier to sleep. And he walked out to the training hall behind his estate. Late at night, he opened the system window and clicked on the random summon game.

I can’t use Ppodong for this job. He’s too big to burrow a mine. But it’s also too time-consuming for humans to do the job.

The longer the construction time, the more expensive it became. The shield method only guaranteed everyone’s safety. It didn’t shorten the construction period. So, Lloyd needed a capable worker who was going to shorten the construction period and save some money.

It’d be best if this summon got some skills related to digging. Lloyd then activated the random game. He still had enough RP around even after all of his upgrading.

[Cost of 2nd Random Summon Game = 70 RP]

[Current RP: 119]

[Would you like to start the random summon game?]

[YES / NO]

He chose “YES.”

[The random summon game is starting.]

Fwoosh!

A bright light enveloped the area. A complex magic circle formed in the air, and the space rumbled. A hazy silhouette gradually appeared in the rumbling space, slowly revealing itself.

Lloyd’s eyes widened when he finally met the summon.

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Chapter 22: Second Random Summon Game (2)

Fwoosh! A bright light enveloped the area. An unfamiliar silhouette started to take shape. The summon revealed itself with a bang and shockwave.

Crackle!

“Bangul!” Something shrieked and flew toward Lloyd. He quickly reached out to save it from hitting the ground. Her skin felt plush in his hands.

What kind of summon partner is this? Lloyd quickly checked to see what it could be.

“Bangul!”

“Huh?”

She was plump and about four inches long. She had a large round head, and her beady eyes glimmered. There was a gold bell attached to the end of her tail with a ribbon.

“A snake…?” Yes. The new summon partner was a snake.

She’s so strangely proportioned. Lloyd wasn’t making fun of her appearance. He was simply making an objective observation of his new friend, whose body and head were of equal size.

“Are you… really a snake?”

“Bangul!” She nodded in the affirmative. Her expression was quite coy.

Then he remembered something. So, he asked, “Is your name Bangul?”

“Bangul! Ba-bangul!” Bangul nodded once again.

Lloyd was right. *Well, it’s nothing surprising for a creature to yell out its name.* That famous yellow cartoon character did the same, yelling ‘peeka

peeka’. That helped him to better understand the relationship between the summon creatures and their language.

Lloyd stared at Bangul. *A short, equally proportioned snake.*… He wondered if she could slither around properly. But he wasn’t the kind of person to make a hasty judgment. He had already experienced Ppodong. That taught him that he must not judge summons based on their looks.

“Hey, Bangul?”

“Bangul?”

“Do you have a manual or something?”

“Ba-bangul? Bangul!”

Lloyd was skeptical, but she really did have one. Bangul opened her mouth wide. There was a bag inside. He opened the bag and found ten sets of sunflower seeds and a neatly folded note. Lloyd read it carefully.

[Bangul User Manual

Bangul is a lovely rattlesnake. Please show her love and care.

Bangul will give her utmost loyalty to you, her master. A summon partner is not only your companion animal but also your family, so please don’t neglect them.

Bangul can change her size by eating one of the enclosed sunflower seeds.]

[Red Sunflower Seed: Bangul grows to gigantic proportions. Effective for maximum of 12 hours.]

[Blue Sunflower Seed: Bangul shrinks back to a smaller size. Feed this to Bangul before the 12-hour limit is up. Bangul will be dehydrated if she goes past the 12-hour limit without eating a blue sunflower seed. She will automatically shrink back to her small size, but she will not be able to grow gigantic for the next 24 hours.]

[One set of each color of sunflower seed costs 1 RP.]

[Bangul can use a wide range of skills while she is gigantic.]

[Bangul's Skill Log]

[Chomping Dirt (Lvl. 1)]

[Accelerated Dirt Digestion (Lvl. 1)]

[Steel Dung Launcher (Lvl. 1)]

Whaaat? Dirt chomping? Accelerated dirt digestion? Steel dung launching? Lloyd's mouth hung wide open in disbelief when he read Bangul's skill log. It was dumbfounding.

Wait a minute, she's not going to poop steel after eating dirt, is she? With lingering doubt, Lloyd brought out a red sunflower seed and gave it to Bangul to test.

"Hey, Bangul?"

"Bangul?"

"Do you want to eat this?"

"Bangul!"

Bangul chewed it up as if she was waiting for it. Lloyd put her down on the ground and stepped back. The moment Bangul swallowed the sunflower seed she was munching on… *Boom!*

"Bangul!"

She became gigantic. Bangul was now sixteen feet tall, but her head and body were still of equal proportion. *Yes, this is nothing new.* He had already experienced the same phenomenon with Ppodong.

Lloyd walked over to Bangul. "Hey, Bangul?"

“Bangul!”

“Do you want to test out your skills?”

“Bangul?”

“You know, eating and digesting dirt, stuff like that. Can you do it?”

“Ba-bangul?” Bangul’s eyes sank as though she was disappointed by her doubtful master.

Lloyd flinched in guilt. *Hmm… She’s a bit snobbish. I guess Ppodong and Bangul are different.* That was how it appeared. So, Lloyd adjusted his tone to sound more like a request.

“Of course I trust you. It’s just that I need to see it. I just want to see how cool you are,” Lloyd cooed.

“Bangul?”

“I mean it.”

“Bangul!” Bangul’s face brightened, and she wriggled her body in happiness. Then she hung her large, round head toward the ground of the hall and opened her mouth.

“Ba-bangul!”

Chomp! Yum! Gulp!

Goodness… She's eating dirt. Is that how I look when I’m eating fried chicken? The way Bangul savored the dirt made him wonder. She scooped the dirt up with her mouth and scarfed it down. After a long while, she let out a big burp.

Then she started to shake her short, chubby tail. “Bangul! Ba-bangul!” *Jingle!* The bell tied to the end of her tail rattled noisily.

Then she lifted her tail high and made a straining expression.

And… *Clank! Clank!* She squeezed out a long, steaming, red-hot turd made of steel.

OMG. It's like she's making popcorn. Lloyd suppressed his embarrassment and examined the steel poo she had just deposited. It was only then that he realized Bangul's true potential.

This is amazing. Her shit was actual steel. And it wasn't shaped like the poop emoji. *It's a steel bar.* It was about thirty-two feet long and the width of a human thumb. The steel bar was polished and perfect, without any bumps. From the start to the end, the steel bar was sleek and smooth.

It was a rod of perfectly reinforced steel rebar. *And it's very hot.* The steel bar poop was still as red and hot as when it came out. This meant just one thing. *I can cut it before it cools down. I can cut or bend the bar in any way I want.*

Lloyd realized that he now had an unlimited supply of steel rebar as long as he just kept feeding her dirt.

This is… Woah. It's too good to be true! It was indeed too good to be true. *Come to think of it, I can do more than produce steel bars from her.* She could eat the dirt. Which meant that she could dig out an underground tunnel. So, if he included Bangul in his plan…

Bangul would eat the dirt in the shield machine and dig a tunnel. At the same time, she would release steel bars, and the blacksmiths would cut them to the needed length right on the spot. The workers would then make and set up the sections of metal walls that would support the mine. Once the metal walls have been erected, we could move the shield and repeat the process.

The construction plan slowly came together in his head. The more he thought about it, the more amazed he became. *If this plan works, the construction period would only be a tenth of what I expected.*

Lloyd only wished for a summon who had the ability to dig the earth. But the one he got turned out to be much better than that. Lloyd stood there,

looking at Bangul in a daze.

“Hey, Bangul?”

“Bangul?”

“You are really something. You’re the best,” Lloyd said.

“Ba-bangul!?”

“No, I correct myself. You are the best, the bomb, the greatest one there is.”

“Bangul!”

Lloyd gave her a thumbs up.

Bangul flashed back a happy grin.

***

After he earned Bangul from the summoning game, construction preparation gained momentum. Lloyd customized his shield machine design for Bangul. The segments and rebar components that made up the walls were fitted accordingly. The construction work now centered around Bangul.

“Ppodong?” “Ppo-do-dong!”

“Bangul?”

“Ppodong!”

“Ba-bangul!”

To Lloyd’s relief, Ppodong and Bangul got along very well. The fact that they were a snake and a hamster combo worried him, but he realized that he was mistaken. Instead, the fuzzy hamster and chubby rattlesnake instantly clicked and became best friends, perhaps because of their shared identity as summon creatures. They stuck with each other, rolling around and playing

on the ground on days without work. They even sunbathed and dozed off to sleep together.

Whew. Good for you two. You can goof around all day, and people will call you cute. While the two summon beasts lazed around, Lloyd busied himself with his tasks.

He visited the forge every day, pestering the blacksmiths. He personally supervised the production of the shield device. After about ten days, they finally completed the shield. It looked like a soda pop can laid down on its side with open ends. Its diameter was about ten feet, and its front area was reserved for Bangul. The dense construction of the sides ensured that the circular shape would remain intact and firm despite the weight of the earth in the mine.

The back area was for the workers. They would be protected by the shield structure there and be able to cut the steel bars Bangul would produce from all the dirt she ate. That allowed them to quickly install the metal walls that would keep the mine from collapsing.

We're all set. The next task was assembling the workers. A group of blacksmiths to cut and shape the hot steel bars underground. An army of civil engineers to push the shield device forward while supporting the blacksmiths. Planning out the division of labor was completed with ease. The baron's approval made things move along seamlessly.

With everything ready, Lloyd began construction. Finally, it was time for the shield device to see the light of day.

"Bangul! Ba-bangul!"

Inside the shield, Bangul moved her large head around. She opened her mouth and swallowed any dirt or rocks in sight. A little later, her stomach wiggled, and she rattled her short tail.

Jingle! Her tail rattled more vigorously.

"It's coming!"

Lloyd’s shout made the blacksmiths nervous. Finally, Bangul blessed the workers with bars of steel poop.

Fwish! The red-hot steel bars flew into the air.

“Hurry up before they cool. Javier!” Lloyd shouted.

At his call, Javier moved quickly. He removed his coat and drew his sword. *Swish!* The long blade shone as coldly as Javier’s face. He wielded the sword like a bolt of lightning, splitting the hot steel bars.

Swoosh! Javier—the expert swordsman—slashed down at the scorching bar with all his strength, and cleanly cut through it. However, there was more.

“Hey! You’re cutting the correct lengths, right?” Lloyd yelled.

“Of course.”

Swoosh! Swoosh! Slice! Slice! Slash! Javier’s long sword brilliantly danced in the air. He sliced the steel bar ruthlessly.

In the original *Knight of Blood and Iron* novel, Javier’s sword struck down powerful enemies with ease. But now he brandished his sword to slice up the metal poo of a summon partner. His precise swordwork reminded him of chefs in seafood restaurants who effortlessly cut fish into equal pieces.

Clank! Clunk!

Dozens of short and long bars littered the ground. Everything was a perfect size. Lloyd gave Javier a thumbs up. “Good! Not a single inch short.”

“Thank you,” Javier said hesitantly. While Lloyd erupted in joy, Javier sighed at length for having been demoted to a steel cutter. Once he finished, it was time for the blacksmiths to work.

“Move before the steel gets cold! Assemble them!” Lloyd shouted.

“Yes, Young Master!” the blacksmiths yelled in unison. “Let’s go!” The blacksmiths moved with shipman-like precision. They bent Javier’s steel

bars according to Lloyd's precise measurements. They carefully weaved, fixed, and assembled them into a wall that fit right into the inner side of the shield.

Once Lloyd was satisfied with the work, he yelled, "Shield! Forward!"

"Forward!" Dozens of civil engineers repeated in unison. They mightily pushed the lever connected behind the shield, and it slowly crawled forward, despite the massive weight of Bangul and the workers. The shield moved three feet, which was the exact distance Bangul had cleared the way for them by eating the earth. When it lurched forward, the three-foot metal walls were released from the shield, holding the ground back behind them.

Rumble! The shield's movement caused the walls and ceiling of the tunnel to shake, but it didn't collapse. The metal walls behind the shield firmly supported them.

Everything was happening just as Lloyd had planned. *Good. It's working.* Lloyd's eyes flashed with determination. His voice now contained more confidence while leading the project.

At the same time, he meticulously examined what was in front of him. *Flash!* He was using his intermediate surveying skill. Lloyd could scan the ground sixteen feet ahead of him that would be dug out later. He studied the geographical characteristics and whether a dangerous gas layer lurked nearby. The skill enabled him to supervise his people while getting a full picture of the work. It was the ultimate method to prevent any construction disasters. His eyes boasted the capability of modern seismic prediction monitors and reflective imagery for observing underground construction sites.

"Okay, people!" Yelled Lloyd. "Let's keep up the momentum!"

"Go, go, go!" The workers enthusiastically replied.

"Bangul!" Shouted Bangul.

The yells of Lloyd and his people, along with Bangul's booming exclamation, rang loud in the underground. They burrowed deeper into the mountain.

The construction went quickly.

But no one suspected what waited for them at the end of the tunnel.

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Chapter 23: Beasts of the Underground (1)

It was a sunny spring day. The sun this year was brighter and warmer than any before it. Thanks to its blessing, the construction in the Frontera barony sailed along smoothly.

Heated flooring system construction continued to take place; one house at a time. The installation rate reached over thirty percent in preparation for the upcoming winter.

The mine construction also proceeded without any problems. The shield method prevented any accidents in the process. The workers were originally anxious about it. But now, they felt relieved. They focused on their work.

There was an atmosphere of vitality in the entire fiefdom. The farmers busily plowed the fields, while the soldiers in the engineering corps kept their noses to the grindstone. The women worked hard to keep the men supplied with meals and drinks. Even the children were busy. In spring they used to go capture frogs. This year, the frogs enjoyed peace for the first time in their lives. Instead of chasing frogs, the kids hung around the construction site. Why? To catch a glimpse of Bangul, the summon partner Lloyd conjured for the project.

“Wow! She’s come out!”

They would shout whenever Bangul made a rare appearance. When they cheered and hollered in excitement, Bangul never disappointed their little hearts. Even though she was out there to rest, she knew how to please her fans.

“Bangul! Ba-bangul!”

She’d take a bite of ground nearby. Then she’d release steel turds as she rattled her tail. Each time she did it, the children’s shouting became more excited. That would bring the resting workers out of the mine to shout:

“Kids! Stop causing a fuss near the construction site! How many times do we have to tell you that it’s dangerous out here!”

“No, it’s not! It’s safe here.”

“You brats! If you don’t listen to adults, ants as big as wolves will come to get you.”

“That kind of ant doesn’t exist!”

“Of course they do. Just wander up the mountain. There are many of those beasts in the eastern wasteland.”

“But there aren’t any here.”

“Whoa! Won’t you stop talking back!”

There was great energy and activity every day in the fiefdom. But not for everyone. There was one exception. That was Ppodong.

“Ppodong… Ppo-do-dong…”

I’m bored. Ppodong yawned at length as he thought to himself. *I must have slept in. Wait, did I wake up in the morning and fall asleep again?*

“Ppo-do-dong…”

He didn’t actually have anything to do even if he did wake up early. That’s how it was for the past few days. Lloyd didn’t take him to the mine. He left him on the estate, advising him to relax and take a break once in a while. The reason was simple. *I’m sorry. I don’t have enough sunflower seeds. I think I barely even have enough for Bangul.*

In order for Lloyd to mobilize his summons, he needed to feed them red sunflower seeds. That would make them gigantic. But Lloyd had a limited supply. They came in red and blue, and he used one RP each time he bought one of them. That’s why Ppodong was left behind in the mansion.

Lloyd thought Bangul would make a better worker as she could dig tunnels much more safely. *“I’m also worried that you might hurt yourself. And the mine is a bit small for you. You can get badly hurt if it collapses. Do you get what I’m saying?”*

Lloyd had merely comforted himself. Ppodong was slightly upset. But he knew that he couldn’t complain. Lloyd was sincere when he said those words. So, ever since construction started, Ppodong was unemployed.

“Ppodong… Ppo-do-dong…”

He rolled one way. And then the other way. Resting did feel nice. But it was too boring. There was no one to play with. For the entire day, he did nothing but roll around. First to the left; then to the right. But after twenty days passed, he resolved that he must take action and bring change to his monotonous existence.

“Ppodong! Ppo-do-do-dong!”

He shook his round head, his plump cheeks swinging. He thought to himself that something must be done.

“Ppodong!”

He needed to do something. The boredom would kill him at this rate. So, he made up his mind to go outside. Resolved, he kicked off his handkerchief and lifted himself up. Slowly, but steadily, he slid down the table leg. Then he waddled towards the door. He crawled up and pressed on the doorknob with his body.

Click. The door opened. And he went out of the room into the hallway.

“Ppodong?”

It was his first time going out this far without Lloyd. When he looked down the long hallway, a feeling of adventure and curiosity — not fear — swelled in his heart.

“Ppodong!”

Let's head out first. Ppodong trotted along the hallway. He went down the stairs and followed the maids. Sometime later… Ppodong found himself in the courtyard of the estate.

"Ppo-do-dong…"

The sun felt warm. The smell of grass in the soft wind pleased him. There was also a sweet scent of flowers coming from somewhere. The aroma led his way, and he followed it until he met eyes with someone.

"Oh!"

Ppodong heard the elegant voice of a human above. He looked up to see who it was. It was Baroness Frontera.

"A mouse…?"

"Ppodong?"

"Are you saying that you are not a mouse?"

"Ppodong!" He nodded.

Baroness Frontera, who was tending to her flower garden, removed her soiled gloves.

"I know now. You are my son's huge summon partner. Am I right?"

"Ppodong!"

"But, what led you into this garden?"

"Ppo-do-dong? Ppodong."

"Hmm, I am sorry, but I cannot understand your words. Could it be… that you came to help me?"

"Ppodong?"

“I understand. Just as I thought. Is that right?”

“Ppo-do-dong?” Ppodong tilted his head to one side.

She smiled in satisfaction. “I’m very grateful. I was, in fact, concerned about my garden lately. Some mice have been ruining it badly.”

“Ppodong?”

“They must be your cousins.”

“Ppo-do-dong? Ppodong?”

“If possible, could you go find them? Please send them a message that I would like to keep my flower garden beautiful.”

“Ppodong?”

“Can you do that?”

“Ppodong?”

Ppodong found himself nodding. But the truth was, he wasn’t a cousin to the mice. He wasn’t sure that they would be able to communicate. But her voice and smile felt so warm that he couldn’t deny her. Besides, her request just gave him something to do, and it would ease the boredom he had been feeling.

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong?”

Ppodong stood up, supporting himself on two feet. He pounded his chest with his tiny paws as if to show his trustworthiness. After agreeing to go on this quest for Baroness Frontera, he rushed into the grass and disappeared.

***

Thwack!

“Push!”

Craaack! The energetic command rang loudly in the tunnel. Workers moved quickly, and the torches in the dark tunnel glinted on the sweaty muscles of the workers. They were covered with bulging veins. The steel shield slowly moved forward, and each time it lurched ahead, huge metal walls were placed behind it. The metal walls supported the weight of the tunnel. Nobody in the mine counted the number of metal walls they had built. They simply moved as they were ordered. As the blacksmiths and engineers panted for air, Lloyd yelled out a command.

“All right! Good job! Switch!”

“Switch!”

“On the double. Rest up. Next group, come in now!”

“Now!”

A group of blacksmiths and engineers moved from behind the shield, and they were replaced by another group.

“Master Lloyd, are you alright?” A blacksmith asked.

Lloyd chuckled. “Why? Are you worried?”

“Well, of course…”

“It’s alright. It’s not like I’m working like all of you are.”

“But if you continue staying here in this hot area, without much air…”

“My, my, you’re moving me to tears. Don’t worry about me. Let’s just get to work.” Lloyd waved him aside. The blacksmith turned and moved away. Lloyd was not fine. *I’m burning.* The mine was hot inside. It wasn’t just warm. The place felt like a sauna. There was also barely any ventilation.

None of this surprised Lloyd, however. The area of excavation sat at the far end of the mine. The blind end. The temperature underground was naturally higher than on land. There was also the heat coming from the workers’ bodies. Additionally, proper ventilation was out of the question as well.

If there was better technology, I'd have come up with a more efficient ventilation system. The construction of the tunnels hugely depended on ventilation. It directly correlated with the workers' safety. It wasn't good to breathe in large amounts of dust, but a lack of oxygen in an enclosed area could become a life-threatening situation. Knowing all this, Lloyd opted to create a makeshift ventilation system.

"Hey! Get your feet off the oxygen pipe," Lloyd shouted sharply. A soldier stepped back in shock, realizing that he had been stepping on a metal pipe as thick as an arm. The pipe served as the only channel to bring in oxygen from outside.

We're holding up because at least we have that. The pipe was connected to the outside of the mine, where several workers operated a lever nonstop. The lever spun a pinwheel, sending air into the pipe to the end where they were.

"You could have created a hole in the pipe! You may not notice it now, but if you create a hole in the pipe, the air is going to get thinner as we go down. There would be no more fresh air coming in. Got that? Watch where you step."

"I… I'm sorry."

"Tsk. Forget it. Let's get to work."

"Y-yes!"

The stuffy and oppressive environment made Lloyd irritable. But he didn't have the luxury to take breaks outside as the others did. *I need to supervise the project all the time.* He had a long list of things to check.

First on the list was the course of the mine. He needed to make sure that the shield was burrowing in the right direction, that is, toward the layer where coal was located. *Thankfully, I have detailed records of the previous baron.* He had paid a great sum to hire wizards and conduct a geographical investigation of the place, meticulously recording the seam of coal they had

found then. They made setting the path much easier. However, he had much more to watch out for.

Dozens of dangers we cannot see lurk underground. Like groundwater or a layer of methane gas. Hit the wrong area, and the underground water could flood the entire tunnel. A layer of methane gas was worse. It was flammable, so it could cause an explosion.

We'd be completely done for. This was the scariest part of the coal mining project.

Coal fed on methoxylated aromatic compounds, breeding methane bacteria that create methane gas. Because of the methane produced by the microorganisms, gas layers inevitably lurked in coal mines.

So, I can't let my guard down for even a second. Lloyd needed to use his surveying skill at least three times a day. What lay ahead needed to be checked on a regular basis. Aside from that, Lloyd had to stay vigilant to watch out for any tail voids between the moving shield and the metal walls.

It can happen because the shield has a larger diameter than the metal wall. The diameter between the advancing shield and the metal walls built did have a slight difference. So that difference would cause the land to sink a little after the shield traveled forward. The difference was merely a couple of inches, but it had the potential to wreak havoc and bury everyone alive. It wasn't something to overlook.

Like I'd let that happen. The scorching heat. The murky air. Lloyd fought to stay focused in the midst of it all. He removed his soaked shirt and sweated in the heat. When he got dizzy, he put his mouth down to the ventilation pipe and inhaled some fresh air. The construction continued like this for several days. The tunnel grew longer, getting closer to the coal he was aiming for.

Just a little more. He struggled to relieve the stress that piled on with the hot and murky air around him. Each morning he woke up, his body felt like it weighed a ton. Everything would be all right if he just endured it for a little bit more. This was not an unfamiliar situation for Lloyd.

It was even worse back then! Compared to the days he spent in his single dorm room in Korea, this felt heavenly. Back there, he could hardly sleep. In the afternoon, his nose bled in the lecture rooms. At night, the same thing happened during his part-time jobs because of sheer exhaustion. But there was more. He had to squeeze in some time to finish a pile of school assignments. The easiest way to make a few more hours in the day was to sleep less.

He cut down his sleep time one hour after another. Sleep deprivation and fatigue became routine. Like a zombie on the verge of collapse, he studied and worked day and night.

But right now, I can eat to my heart's content and get a good night's sleep. It's only hard during the actual construction time. The food quality was incomparably better here than during his days as a student.

All I had was the free rice and kimchi the dormitory offered! These memories straightened out his attitude. He never wanted to go back to those days. He resolved every day to make this fiefdom more prosperous. That determination and resolve became the drive that kept the construction going without pause.

As the days progressed, Bangul and the workers became more proficient. The construction was picking up its pace. And finally, many days later, Lloyd's surveying skill led to the seam of coal.

It finally appeared. Just sixteen feet from their base awaited a rich black bed of coal. Treasure from underground… Coal.

"All right, we're almost there! Let's go!"

"Let's go!"

"Bangul!"

Lloyd shouted in excitement. The workers and Bangul cheered with him. Even the usually calm Javier shouted with the rest. Everyone felt it. The difficult digging was nearing its end.

They could finally see the light at the end of the tunnel.

“Bba-bangul!”

Bangul gobbled up one more chunk of soil right before the coal bed.

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Chapter 24: Beasts of the Underground (2)

“Bangul!”

Chomp! Bangul opened her mouth wide and ate a large chunk of soil in one big bite. And there it was. Something black filled the space where the soil had been. Up until right now, Bangul had been chomping on nothing but dirt. Occasionally, gray rocks appeared stuck in the soil. But this was different.

“It’s bituminous coal. Hey, Bangul. Stop!” Lloyd quickly ordered his summon partner. At last, the seam of coal appeared before them. This meant everything in the walls of the mine was precious coal. It was too valuable for Bangul to eat.

“The important part of our job starts now. Everyone stay focused.”

He calmed down the workers, who were about to let out a cheer of excitement. Disasters and accidents would take place the second they let their guard down. That moment would have been now if everyone let loose just before reaching their goal. Reassuring himself that now was the time to focus, Lloyd quickly told everyone, “We’re not done yet. We just made it to the threshold of the coal deposit. We can cheer later. The celebration can happen once we make this score. Okay? So, good job everyone. Time to change shifts and tell the guys to bring the support pillars.”

They needed to start careful excavation work now. Lloyd sent out the exhausted workers and called in a fresh crew. While he was waiting for them to come down, he held a blue sunflower seed out to Bangul.

“Hey, Bangul?”

“Bangul!”

“Yes, you did a very good job. I mean it when I say that. We couldn’t have dug down this far so quickly without you.”

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

“Haha, okay. I’ll feed you something good once we go back up. But right now, will you be happy with this?”

“Bangul!”

He put the blue sunflower seed in her mouth. Bangul happily swallowed it. *Gulp!* Three seconds later, Bangul became small again.

“Bangul!”

“All right! Good job. Thank you.” He took her in his arms. The new workers finally arrived, carrying support pillars over their shoulders.

“As you can all see, we finally found the coal. This is the most important part. We’re going to expand this end of the mine along the seam of coal. It’s a dangerous job, so you have to follow my instructions carefully. Am I clear?”

Everyone nodded.

Lloyd activated his intermediate surveying skill.

Measure. Crackle! A faint light flashed before his eyes. Then, information about the mine and the coal appeared as he looked around.

Thankfully, the ground near the coal is firm. We can do without the shield, and the place won’t collapse. The coal seam is stretched to… okay, this way. Lloyd turned around and faced the workers. “Okay, so we’ll dismantle the shield. As slowly and carefully as possible.”

The shield was no longer needed, but they couldn’t push it up to the ground. So, the only available option was to dismantle it back to its component parts.

“Okay, grab that part. Two, three, pull!”

Clunk! Lloyd ordered, and the workers moved. One by one, they disassembled the shield.

By the time they were almost done with it, Lloyd shouted, “Bring the support pillars!”

Three workers who were waiting for his command jumped to their feet right away. They carried the support pillars and the upper and lower planks over their shoulders and headed into the blind end of the mine. The planks and pillars were set up where the shield had been installed seconds ago. The makeshift device was meant to prevent the blind end from collapsing.

“Let’s get started with the reinforcement work. Don’t forget what we practiced!”

“Yes, sir!”

Everyone worked together like parts of a machine. They shoveled along the walls. The end of the tunnel was widened. Temporary supporting planks and pillars were installed. They worked to secure more mining space.

Meanwhile, Lloyd continued surveying. He kept an eye on the walls and ceiling at all times for signs of crumbling. They would have to evacuate everyone if they should collapse. Fortunately, the work proceeded without a hitch or any hints of a cave-in.

It’s done. The most difficult part was over. It was time to call it a day. And if they continued the reinforcement work tomorrow? At this pace, they would be able to mine the coal starting next month. “Whew.” At last, he relaxed with relief. The worn-out and sweaty faces of the workers brightened. The mine was dug out at last.

“All right, you guys did a good job. Let’s go up. Tonight, we’re going to party. There’ll be meat, booze, and a hefty bonus.”

Work hard, play hard. That was Lloyd’s motto. Such a principle was already known to the workers who had been with Lloyd for many months now.

“Woah! It’ll be a good bonus this time too, right?”

“Where should I spend all that money?

“Wait for me, Rosalia. Your brother will pay for all your tuition!”

Digging the mine was more difficult than any other project. The heated flooring system and road paving were nothing compared to this. So that meant the bonus for this job would be larger. This put a big smile on everyone’s face. They sashayed around as they arranged the tools. Their hearts felt lighter as if they were already out of the mine.

But, just at that happy moment…

Thud.

There was a faint sound coming from the coal seam. Lloyd turned toward the source of the sound. *What was that? Rocks falling?*

And then another…

Thud…!

This time, the sound was louder.

Lloyd looked down at the ground, but there were no fallen rocks. And the thudding noise came again from the other end of the coal seam. *What is that?* Something felt odd. He felt something was seriously wrong. No sound should have been coming from there.

By reflex, Lloyd activated his survey skill. *Measure. Crackle!* He studied the coal deposit, and his eyes widened in surprise. *What?*

Lloyd saw a cave about ten feet away. It wasn’t there before. The cave, which was about six feet wide, was getting bigger as he watched. *What the…!? Is something collapsing? No. Nothing’s sinking.* Lloyd realized that something was burrowing a hole in his direction. Whatever it was, it was digging fast.

Whip!

The mysterious burrower popped its head out.

It was a gigantic ant. Its head was twice as big as a watermelon. Its elongated mandibles extended longer than a human arm.

“What? Argh!”

Lloyd fell down on his butt as he hurriedly backed away. Lucky that he did.

Clack! The ant swooped ahead and snapped its mandibles shut right in front of Lloyd; so close that it almost touched his nose. Its mandibles — as sharp as sawblades — glistened in the torchlight.

If it bites me, it’s taking an arm or a leg off… or two, for sure… A chill ran down his spine.

“What is that?! Why is there an ant here?!”

“Ackkk!”

Panic-stricken shouts erupted from the workers. They were terrified by the sudden appearance of the ant and the sheer size of it. It was as big as a wolf. They had no time to stop and think about that. Lloyd fumbled around on the ground, trying to grab anything that would help. He managed to grab his pure steel shovel. Lifting it up high, he swung it in the direction of the ant.

Wham!

The sharp head of the shovel dug into the side of the ant’s head.

“Kieek!”

The stricken ant shrieked. It shook its head in pain. A transparent fluid spurted out of its head and splattered all over Lloyd’s face. The spray snapped him out of his trance.

“Everybody, run!” He yelled by instinct. The petrified workers rushed toward the entrance of the mine. Lloyd tried to get on his feet, but the ant didn’t let him.

“Skreee!”

Now, clearly pissed off by the attack, the ant hurtled toward Lloyd. Its mandibles opened again, aimed straight at Lloyd’s neck. Lloyd was still rooted to the ground.

Argh!

Lloyd was desperate to avoid its counterstrike, but he was in no position to do so. He could feel the danger drawing closer, the mandibles inching forward to chop his head off.

Damn.

Just then.

Slash!

He saw a flash of silver light above his head.

Swish! Swoosh!

The fierce mandibles got sliced off.

Wham!

Another silver flash dove deep into its forehead. The sword penetrated the ant’s head, the blade driven into the ground like a nail. As the sword twisted, the crunching sound of the ant’s head shattering to pieces followed.

“Skreee!”

After some wriggling, the ant hung limp. Lloyd saw the sword being pulled out of the monstrous ant, and someone offered a hand in his direction.

“Are you okay, young master?”

The firm calloused palm. The calm and composed expression. It was Javier. He was holding out his hand. Lloyd quickly grabbed it and sprang to his feet.

“What in the world is that?!”

“I don’t know, but…”

“But?”

“I speculate that they are the beast ants that inhabit the wilderness across the mountain range.”

“Beast ants? What are they doing here?”

Lloyd was seriously baffled. Supposedly, these giant ants lived in the eastern wilderness across the mountain range. So it made no sense for them to show up underground. The whole thing didn’t make any sense.

“The ant cave must have expanded underground near this area without our knowledge. If that’s not the case…”

“Well?”

Just then, another giant ant climbed out of the coal hole. As soon as it laid its compound eyes on the two, it charged toward them, swinging its thick antennae like baseball bats.

“They must have heard us tunneling and snuck up in their own holes to attack us.”

Whack!

Javier’s sword swung in a flash of silver once again. The ant’s head was split in half vertically. However, there was another one right behind it. Lloyd suddenly realized that the ants would continue to come out of the hole one after another in an endless stream.

“Aw, shit.”

Javier’s second assumption sounded plausible. *When I first discovered the seam of coal a while ago, I didn’t see any caves behind it.* He was certain. He had used the surveying skill to keep a close eye on their surroundings. There wasn’t any sign of ant caves. It was only later that he discovered the ant cave and the giant ants.

What should I do? This took him by surprise. It stung that he didn’t prepare for this. *There wasn’t any record of ant caves in the former baron’s records. I should’ve been more careful and prepared for it.* He did know that preparing for undocumented circumstances hardly sounded plausible. It was an impossible job, but regardless of that, this happened. So, he needed to find a solution.

Do we need to stop them here? The confusion and fatigue. The stifling heat. He frantically racked his brain. There was only one thing he was certain of. *If the ants get out of the mine, we’re done for.* The exit led to the fiefdom, and disaster was inevitable if the ants crawled out of the mine.

The soldiers wouldn’t be able to protect the place. The sheer number of ants made it impossible. Worst-case scenario, the entire place gets wiped out. The situation would get completely out of hand.

I can’t let that happen. The mere thought of it caused him to sweat. But Javier seemed to have misread Lloyd.

“Master Lloyd, pull yourself together.”

Pop! Javier softly punched Lloyd in the gut, winding him.

“Ack…!” Lloyd panted for air. Javier probably meant to give a light tap, but the surprise punch hurt a lot.

“Hey, what was that for?!”

“You cannot let fear get to you in situations like these.”

“I’m not scared! I was just thinking about what I should do next!”

“Then, please give me a solution.”

Swish! Crack! Even while Javier was fending off the army of ants, he was calmly responding to his young master. Javier wasn’t out of breath in the slightest. Each time he swung, Javier either split or chopped off an ant’s head. But his upper torso was thoroughly soaked in sweat. Having already removed his shirt, his sweaty muscles shone against the light.

This is bad. Yes, it’s Javier, but he still has his limits. Lloyd knew this by instinct. Javier was strong, of course. But the place they were stuck at was the blind end of the mine with crippling ventilation. Even Javier would eventually reach his limit as he fought endlessly with an army of angry ants.

I need to come up with a solution while he is still holding up. How should I block the ants without leading them to the barony in the least damaging way possible? Should I just collapse the mine? No, that’s impossible. The metal walls are too robust, and damaging the structure in one or two places would barely do anything. Besides, the ants dig way too fast even if I succeed in destroying the mine. Lloyd shook his head.

One wrong move and everyone could get wiped out by the colony of giant ants. *This won’t work with a half-assed plan. I need something to firmly block the ants and get rid of them in one blow… Eh? Hold on.* Then a solution hit him.

Lloyd lifted his head. He looked at Javier, shouting, “Hey! Javier! Do you think you could break through them?”

“Break through?” *Swoosh!* “ I do not understand what you mean,” Javier said as he sliced off a charging ant’s antennae in one clean sweep.

Lloyd shouted. “Of course, you know! Breaking through these ants and charging ahead! Can you do it?!”

“Charge through these ants?”

“Yes.”

Javier turned to look at Lloyd. His face silently told him to stop spouting nonsense when he was busy enough fighting ants.

This time, Lloyd shouted more nonchalantly. “I think it’s the only way to save everyone and stop these ants! Can’t believe it? Or scared? Run away if you’re scared!”

“Are you insinuating that I am scared?”

“Of course.”

“Such misunderstanding is not welcome.”

“So? Can you do it?”

“Of course. But break through them? How far?”

“Right into the ant’s nest!”

“Wait, into it? Until the end?”

“Yes.”

“Do you have a plan in mind?”

“Sure thing! I’ve got a brilliant plan! What? Can’t trust me?”

“No need to ask such an obvious question.”

“Hey! Really? Now’s not the time…”

“I pray that your brilliant method is not something insane.”

It appeared he made a resolution. Or it could be that he resigned and realized he had no other choice but to obey Lloyd. *Crack!* The grip around his sword tightened. His voice grew more menacing.

“Make sure that you stay close behind me. Do not wander and get lost.”

Javier’s blade flashed in such a lethal manner that it looked like his sword was brewing a storm.

Swish! Slash! Slash!

Lloyd admired the glimmering sword that danced in Javier’s hands. Five ants rushing toward them got sliced into pieces. Javier jumped in between them. His movement reminded Lloyd of a silvery beast. Lloyd ran after his knight with a torch and steel shovel in his hands.

“Run! Don’t stop!”

In a split second, he entered the inner part of the ant nest, beyond the hole in the coal seam. Thankfully, the colony of ants didn’t crawl up toward the entrance of the mine. Instead, they turned around and pursued the human intruders. Javier and Lloyd sliced and chopped down the ants that blocked their way. They ran without stopping into the ant nest.

“Continue running down!”

Lloyd obsessively scanned the ant cave with his survey skill as he ran.

This is the only solution right now. I must give it a try no matter what.

There was only one thing Lloyd was looking for: the methane gas layer deep in the ant cave.

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Chapter 25: Beasts of the Underground (3)

“My lord! W-we have a serious problem!!”

The baron had been enjoying the afternoon sun when he was rudely interrupted. A soldier burst into his office unannounced bearing startling news. The baron dropped his teacup, which tumbled onto the floor.

Kee-rash! Clink, clink, clink.

“What…?” The baron’s face turned pale as a sheet. “Tell me that again. Did you just say ants? Giant ants?”

“Yes, my lord. Giant beast ants appeared in Master Lloyd‘s mine.”

“Where is Lloyd?”

“The workers said that he chose to stay behind and told everyone else to flee…”

“Is he alone?”

“No. Sir Asrahan is with him.” The soldier’s face became tearful after he gave his report. Everyone in the room had heard about the beast ants that lived beyond the eastern mountain range. Those creatures instilled fear in the land. Every single ant had the strength and savagery of a wolf. And they came in great numbers. They were without fear and moved in force. To confront the creatures was to guarantee your own death. The chances of surviving an encounter with them where they burrow underground were slim to none.

“Sir Bayern has mobilized the soldiers and assembled them at the mine entrance. He is ready to seal the mine.”

That was the best they could do. If the ant colony left the mine, they would wipe out everything in their path. The villagers would be massacred. The people and livestock would be turned into meat dumplings stuffing. If you

were lucky, you would be paralyzed and taken alive to be put away in storage. At least you'd have a chance. Otherwise, you would become a hearty meal for little ant babies. So, to prevent such a disaster from unfolding, the mine had to be shut down. The baron, however, remained silent after hearing this plan.

"My lord? Sir Bayern has told me to receive orders from you, my lord…"

Nervous and confused, the soldier glanced at his lord. The baron remained silent for some time. Seconds later, he sprang to his feet and opened the armoire in his office. He began to put on the armor that was kept inside.

"My lord?" The soldier called, but the baron did not respond. The only sound in the office came from clanking metal armor.

Clack! Click!

He put a steel-studded brigandine on his chest and silvery poleyn knee guards. The baron strapped demi-greaves over his shins and placed a bascinet on his head. Next, he strapped an iron-framed shield onto his back and hung a well-worn long sword at his hip. He was clearly preparing for battle.

The soldier watched his lord suiting up while he wore a befuddled expression, as surely the baron had not carried a sword in at least the last decade.

"My lord? What…"

"Let us go."

"Excuse me?"

"I shall leave you behind if you do not follow me."

Slam! The baron rushed out of the office, almost kicking open the door. He ran down the stairs and headed to the stable and hopped onto a horse.

"Go!" He prodded the flanks of the horse.

At that moment, the baron was preoccupied with only one concern. W*ait for me just a little longer Lloyd. You must hang in there!* He rushed to the mine at a gallop, with his heart growing more desperate each second.

***

Thwaaack! Slash!

Javier leaped up off the ground and swung his sword through the air. He aimed to drop right on top of an ant's head. *Whack!*

"Skreee!"

Another giant ant dead, its head split in half. The scream was accompanied by a spray of translucent liquid that spattered out in all directions. Before the effluvium could splash on the ground his sword was already aimed at his next target. The blade shone with a cool light.

Swoosh! Clatter! Stab!

Javier slashed an ant's side and twisted the blade in its thorax. He kicked the abdomen aside and deflected an incoming attack. He stabbed, slashed, and swung his sword. As soon as the sword slashed down on one it was thrust forward towards another ant.

One slash on the left, another on the right. Slice the upper left and stab the side. And a blow to the head? Lloyd clucked his tongue as he ran through the narrow mine. He was impressed. He couldn't help it. Javier was charging forward two steps ahead, and he couldn't help but praise the swordsmanship on display in front of him.

Dang. He's amazing. That's the skill of a true knight. Sir Neumann was nothing compared to Javier. His movements flowed like a river, each and every step unhindered and free. But at the same time, each strike was fatal. There were small movements that his eyes couldn't keep up with. His sword flashed for several seconds, masterfully attacking, and deceiving his opponent in a series of impressive maneuvers. In short, Javier's

swordsmanship bordered on art. The wild ant hoards were slashed away with his elegant, yet powerful sword strikes.

“Hey! Aren’t you getting tired?” Lloyd yelled as he followed behind.

Javier glanced behind as he fought. “I am tired.” He answered in a calm and monotonal voice.

No one would be able to tell he was tired from his voice alone. But Lloyd knew. *We don’t have much time.* Sure, Javier was strong, but he was still just human. He had his limits. No one could fight forever. Had Javier reached the level of a sword master, the endless circulation of mana would have kept him strong and robust no matter what. But he wasn’t there yet. Right now, the Asrahan Core Technique was only slowing down his fatigue. But that would eventually reach its limit too.

“Master Lloyd, when is your brilliant plan going to kick in?” *Slash!* Javier inquired as he sliced an ant blocking the way into three pieces.

Lloyd frowned. “Not yet!”

“When will it start?”

“I don’t know. I’m trying my best to look for it!”

“Look for it…?”

“Hush! Keep clearing the way. The more we move, the greater our chance of survival!” Lloyd shouted with some irritation. It was true. Even now, Lloyd was pushing his surveying skill to its limit. He had been scanning the cave without stopping for a second. He was scanning frantically to find the methane gas layer that was hidden somewhere below the ant nest.

I’m sure it’s here. This area is dotted with bituminous coal. Methane gas is bound to be here. Lloyd kept running. With Javier taking the lead, Lloyd sprinted around the ant cave. He scanned everywhere, keeping the skill range to a minimum. After a while of frantic and desperate scanning, Lloyd finally caught sight of something.

Found it! He caught a slight amount of methane gas beneath the ground. It wasn't the main reserve of gas. Just a small stream of it. *But I can't get full access from here*. A sixteen-foot-wide layer of soil and rock sat between the cave and the gas. It would take more than a month to dig that deep with his shovel. Bangul was not an option, since the cave was too small for her to grow large.

"Javier! Over there!" Lloyd pointed at a passageway that ran in the direction of the methane gas layer.

"From now on, run wherever I point. Okay?!"

"I understand. But…"

"But?"

"Will we make it out alive?" Javier glared at Lloyd as he calmly sliced open an ant. His look signaled he was ready to die here.

Lloyd found himself chuckling when he saw Javier's look of dire resolve. "What? You're scared?"

"I am not scared, but…"

"Then?"

"I think it is a bit unfair."

"That you might die here?"

"No."

"What, did you hide a stash of porn under your bed or something? Are you scared that people might find them after you're gone?"

"Of course not. To be fully honest…" Javier sighed at length. "I do not like how I am going to die with a man like you."

"Wow."

“It’s my selfish desire as a knight. I personally believe that the most honorable death a knight can encounter is sacrificing his life for someone more respectable and worthy.”

“Ha-ha… So, you think it sucks that you will perish side by side with a hooligan like me?”

“That is perfectly correct.”

“Yeah? Look at you; speaking so shamelessly.”

“Well, what is the good of hiding it when we are both bound to perish here?”

“So, you’re showing your true colors, yeah?”

“I said it because I thought I should be honest about it at least once before I die.”

Clatter! Thwack! Slash!

The colony of ants kept charging in their direction. The soldier ants stood guarding the nest, trying to stop Lloyd and Javier from moving forward. Each time they did so, Javier chopped them up. Lloyd was panting for air as he followed. With his torch and steel shovel, he kept back the colony that was chasing them. And so, they used their bodies to fight the ants. Just as they used their mouths to quarrel with each other.

“Ha! Fine! We might as well have a heart-to-heart talk since we’re about to die anyway!”

“Heart-to-heart talk?”

“Yeah! Let’s forget our rank and just talk honestly. Woah!”

“I like that. Hah!”

Clang! Slash!

Both ran into the left passageway. Javier swung his sword while Lloyd held up his torch and wielded his shovel. Their bickering continued. Naturally, Lloyd shouted first.

“I’ll start then. You’re so annoying!”

“How so?”

“You’re too good-looking!”

“But I was born with this face.”

“Yes, exactly!”

“Are you done?”

“What if I’m not?”

“I will simply get my turn. It would be unfair to only get insulted one-sidedly like this.”

“Oh, yeah? Saving time?”

“Yes.”

“That’s good for you because time is gold, my friend. Although, of course, you don’t have either of those things! You’re crying? Huh? Why are you letting my words beat you up?”

“For a second, I pitied you.”

“Wait, why?”

“Come to think of it, my nipples are more good-looking than you.”

“What…?”

That blow was stronger than he expected. He clenched his teeth and struck back. “Ha! But how come you never had a girlfriend with that face of

yours?”

“I devoted all of my time to swordsmanship training.”

“A-ha, so that’s why you’ve been single all this time?”

“The same goes for you, Master Lloyd.”

“What?!”

“From what I know, you have always been single. As for me…”

“What?”

“I have received a fair amount of love letters from women.”

“What? Love letters?”

“Yes.”

Javier swung his sword. Lloyd witnessed Javier’s eyes brimming with confidence.

Lloyd deflected an ant’s strike and asked, “How many times?”

“Uhm, I have about two cartons of them.”

“Liar!”

“I am telling the truth.”

“No way! We’re a small fiefdom. You would have to have received a letter from all the women in the land to collect that amount.”

“Heh.”

“Hey, don’t look down on me for being single!”

Master Lloyd, your girlfriend lives in a nation called the imagination.”

Lloyd attempted to hide a grimace.

“You are single by choice, right? Someone else’s choice, that is.”

Lloyd glared at Javier.

“Are you going to meet your imaginary girlfriend in your dreams tonight?”

“You son of a… Stop there!” Lloyd shouted.

But it wasn’t because he was out of comebacks. No. They had finally arrived at their destination. Javier must have noticed it too, as his look changed.

“Are we here?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd looked around them. He could see into the ground below them, and there was an empty space as wide as five feet. But it was not empty. *That’s the methane gas layer. It’s so huge.* The area he saw with his skill was only the tip of the iceberg. There surely was more down there. Lloyd spat out his plan.

“I’m going to burrow into the ground here. While I do that, you protect me.”

“Understood.”

They shared the same miserable fate, and they only had each other right now. They didn’t have a reason or need to doubt the other person. Lloyd began frantically shoveling the ground. Javier protected him from the incoming ants.

Just then…

“Skreee!”

Something terrifying screeched at the other end of the passageway. The entire cave rumbled as it approached. It finally revealed itself. The head was twice as big as the giant soldier ants', and its body almost filled the passageway. Its mandibles were as long and sharp as a longsword.

The queen ant? It appeared so. However, Lloyd didn't care much about her appearance. *I'm not going after the queen ant!*

This wasn't one of the battle arena video games where you have to behead the boss to win. Even if he were to capture the queen, the rest of the ants would barely budge. Worse case, it would just fire them up more. So, the best course of action was to focus on his original plan.

"You need to properly block her! Until I'm done digging!"

"Understood."

Javier raised his long sword. He guarded Lloyd from the ant queen. This must have angered her because she charged straight toward Javier.

"Skreee!!"

Thud! Thud! Thud!

The queen ant's body was larger than the narrow passageway, but she pushed herself to widen the tunnel and attack Javier. But he stood his ground, not taking one step back.

"Ohm.." He steadied his breathing.

Each time he breathed in, the mana around him fluttered. It rumbled and focused on him. It came together to form a triple circle. The mana increased and flowed out.

Slash! Clang!

The triple circle long sword. The mandibles of the ginormous insect. The two weapons clashed forcibly. The first encounter ended in a draw.

Clang! Clang!

“Skreee?”

Javier’s long sword and ant queen possessed the same amount of strength. Javier’s eyes squinted in a penetrating glare. The ant queen twitched its antennae. The two manifested equal amounts of devastating power. Both were taken aback by the strength of their enemy.

But the ant struck first.

“Skreee!”

Whoosh!

Its huge antennae were thicker and longer than softball bats.

Javier ducked to avoid the blow. Using the momentum, he lifted his sword. The ant deflected the blow with her head. And so began the battle between Javier and the ant queen. The two went all out in their attacks, using every skill and offensive technique they could employ. They blocked and swung forward. They kicked and punched. They hacked and shoved. They got shoved and struck back. They dodged and attacked. They rolled and dashed. Victory, however, was leaning in favor of the ant as the fight carried on.

He’s getting tired! Lloyd’s shoveling sped up. He was tired as well, but he considered his burden nothing compared to Javier, who was fighting for his life.

Just some more! A little more! If Javier fainted, it was over for him. With him gone, the plan would fail. The beast ants would reach the surface.

Crap! I shouldn’t have constructed the mine to be so solid! It was too late to demolish the mine. Even if he tried, it would barely be effective. The mine would collapse only in parts, and that wasn’t enough to stop the ants.

Thus, I must succeed. Lloyd became more earnest in his shoveling. Dirt was scattered in all directions every time he moved his shovel. Streams of sweat

flowed down his neck and back. At last, he succeeded in digging out the desired spot. *Yes!*

Pshhh! A plume of methane gas spurted out of the hole he'd just dug. Lloyd hurriedly grabbed his shovel and shouted to Javier, "Hey! Come over here!"

Javier responded right away. With one powerful slash, he protected himself against the queen and rushed to Lloyd's side.

Lloyd waited until Javier started to run to him. And they began to run toward the opposite passageway together.

The ant queen chased fiercely after them.

Lloyd turned around and made eye contact with the ant. At that moment he laughed and hurled the torch toward the ant. It hit her smack in the head. With a thud, the torch bounced off, flying over the back of the ant, and met the invisible methane gas spreading throughout the passageway. Flame and gas danced together, igniting a violent chemical reaction.

Burning methane produces 891 kilojoules of energy per mole of methane molecules. Thought Lloyd… *Boom…*

Ka-boom!

The massive explosion engulfed everything around it.

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Chapter 26: Double Circle (1)

Thwomp.

A chunk of dirt fell from the ceiling and onto Lloyd's face.

His itchy eyelids twitched, but he couldn't raise a hand to brush it away. He wanted to shake his head to shift it off, but this proved harder than he thought.

I feel so wasted. But it's not so bad. Everything swirled in front of his eyes. His head felt empty and distant. That probably explains the hallucinations.

What now? It feels like the CGI thingies are getting closer. Someone was in front of him. The glowing mushrooms on the walls lit it softly. Lloyd decided it couldn't be human.

It actually was a human, but Lloyd refused to consider that possibility because of the sheer out-of-the-world handsomeness of the person. *Dang, he's too good-looking.* Silvery hair and blue eyes. A perfectly symmetrical face, to the point that he looked like a painting. The smudges on his skin hardly affected his beauty. Though his face was peppered with drops of sweat and blobs of dirt, the man looked as handsome as ever. Heck, he even looked charming in a different way because of the dirt. He looked macho. Which stood in stark contrast to his usually noble visage.

Crap. I'm getting annoyed seeing his face. It wasn't fair that a man could be that handsome. His mere existence disrupted the ecosystem. Lloyd was convinced that this guy could not be human. He was a CGI projection that could somehow eat, sleep, talk… Just keep telling yourself it's only human or you will become too self-conscious to continue wanting to live.

"Master… Lloyd, are you okay?"

Don't talk to me, CGI. I'm dizzy. I feel like throwing up.

But CGI Javier lifted his hand, not knowing that an inferiority complex was killing Lloyd on the inside. Then he suddenly slapped Lloyd in the face. *Thwack!*

“Wake up.” *Thwack!* “You must not close your eyes here.”

“Stop… Stop right there!” Lloyd said, as his senses very slowly came back to him.

There was an urgency in the way Lloyd said ‘stop’. So, Javier put down his hand before he could slap Lloyd a third time. Now he looked relieved.

“Are you okay, lord?”

“No, not at all. It’s all your fault.”

“Pardon?”

“You’re quite a slapper.”

“Thank you.”

“Wow.”

“Do you think you can get on your feet?”

“I don’t think so. Someone just slapped me with a whole lot of gusto.”

“I was simply doing what was necessary.”

“Yeah, right.”

“Please get to your feet.” Javier held out his hand.

But Lloyd realized that Javier couldn’t help him up. The reason was simple. Javier was sprawled out flat on the ground.

“Hey. Did you hurt your legs?”

“Yes.”

“Which part?”

“I fear I sprained my ankle.” Javier pointed at his injured ankle. *Could the pain be severe?*

Lloyd noticed that there was cold sweat dripping down Javier’s forehead. “Does it hurt that much? To the point that you can’t stand up?”

“I hurt both of my ankles.”

“A-ha, so when you held out your hand a while ago, was it because you wanted me to help you out of here?”

“Yes.”

What a shameless brat! “What do you think I am, a taxi service?”

“What’s a ‘taxi’?”

“Well, it’s a thing. Never mind. Hold on for a second.”

Lloyd studied the condition of his little party. Javier injured both of his legs. Bangul passed out in his arms. But Lloyd was fine, without any major fractures or wounds. He was in perfect condition… apart from the many scrapes and bruises all over his body that ached like hell. *This freaking hurts so bad.* His entire body was a big ball of pain.

It was like the morning after a hellish workout with an overly enthusiastic physical trainer with intimidating musculature. He felt exhausted, as though he had been thrown into a washing machine that ran all day. Quite literally every muscle and joint in his body ached. *I think even my armpit hairs ache! It’s a miracle that I survived this.*

Lloyd looked around his surroundings with the help of the glowing mushrooms that sprouted throughout the tunnel. The first thing that caught his attention was the ruined pathway. Next, he noticed the shredded pieces of the ant queen scattered around.

That’s when it dawned on him… How had they managed to survive the explosion? *The ant queen acted as a shield, saving us all.* The methane gas exploded behind them. However, the ant queen stood between the raging fire and the two of them.

The gigantic ant was big enough to cover the entire pathway. Her sheer size saved us, like a cork that stops a champagne bottle from popping. Her ginormous body acted as the cork and took the brunt of the explosion. *Thankfully, that dispersed the flames.* If she wasn’t there, all of them would be dead.

We were lucky. It goes without saying what would’ve happened if most of the explosion wasn’t blocked by that ant. They would have been scorched to ashes. The torn-apart remains of the ant queen made that apparent. *The blast must have been terrifying, really. I mean, that ant survived even when Javier harnessed all his powers into the sword and hit her.*

A chill ran down his spine. Shaking the goosebumps away, Lloyd said, “Let’s get moving right away. We’re gonna die here if we stick around.” Luck had saved them from the blast. But it was too soon for them to let their guard down. The grim situation was as gloomy as it was before the explosion.

“Do you think the ants on the other side are dead?” Javier looked back and examined the crumbled tunnel as he got back on his feet with Lloyd’s support.

Lloyd nodded his head. “Probably.” It had to literally be hell where the explosion started. The beast ants would have surely burned to death in the fire. And any ants that managed to survive? “Most of the tunnel should have collapsed. They were probably buried alive under the weight of the dirt. Those that survived somehow would obviously be dying due to lack of oxygen.”

The ant nest ran all through the coal deposit. The fire must have started there, producing a large volume of toxic gas. And the ants seemed to have died while surrounded by the terrible heat and fumes.

“You can comfortably assume that the ants on the other side have been exterminated.”

Even with modern technology, fire, and explosions are a terrifying prospect for workers underground. Regardless of advanced safety precautions and systems, workers died every year on construction sites. Giant ants were no exception. A huge gas fire would suck up all the oxygen, making it impossible for the ants to survive.

“Anyway, let’s evacuate. Here we go. Aargh!”

It was time for them to leave the site alive. Lloyd flexed his arm which supported Javier and helped lift him up. Then, he turned around quickly, bent over, and said, “Ride on my back.”

“Excuse me?”

“I’ll give you a piggyback ride.”

“Thank you.”

“Wow.”

Javier immediately climbed on him without any hesitation. Once he rested comfortably on Lloyd’s back, he tilted his head to the side and asked, “Master Lloyd, did you…”

“What?”

“Did you think that I would hesitate?”

“Yes, out of courtesy.” It was the truth. Lloyd expected that Javier would refuse once or twice. He even prepared a typical response such as any man would give, “I hate doing this for a grownup.” But Lloyd failed to predict that Javier was a brash and thick-skinned man.

“You made a wise decision. It is reasonable. This allows more mobility than supporting me with both of your arms.”

“Hey, I think you’re mistaken to think that I’d definitely take you out of here.”

“Are you going to leave me here then?”

“That depends on how you behave.”

“But I am already on your back.”

“And you’re ridiculously heavy. Why are you so heavy when you look so thin and scrawny? It turned out that Javier weighed way more than Lloyd had expected. All the muscles in Javier’s body made Lloyd feel like he was carrying a huge bale of iron.

“It could be that you have poor stamina. Not that I am heavy,” Javier said.

“Woah, you’re seriously making me want to throw you off and leave here alone.”

“I will not let go of you.”

“What are you, a leech?” Lloyd huffed.

“I bet you never saw a leech as handsome as me.” Javier smiled.

“God bless you with your brazenness. Now you’re just bragging.”

“I shall lend you my mana.”

“Yeah, I’m so thankful. Should I be grateful to you for patronizing my taxi service? I might as well bend over backward for you,” Lloyd answered.

“You mentioned the ‘taxi’ a while ago. But now, what does bend over backward mean? How do you do that?”

“Oh, never mind. Just make sure that you hold me tight.”

“Will do.”

Lloyd kept moving as he bickered with Javier. But he was already exhausted. Every time he got tired, Javier blew his mana into Lloyd. He was giving him the mana of a high-level sword expert through the triple circle Asrahan Core Technique. It had a tremendous effect. Each time Javier fueled Lloyd with mana, he felt like a tractor, all fueled up and ready to go plow the fields.

“Huff! My strength is growing nicely! Huff! Huff!”

“Do you want some more?”

“Oh my, your precious mana being poured into a shabby body like mine. Shut up and give me more. Come on. I’m just seconds away from collapsing. No joke.”

“I understand. But may I remind you that the technique gets less effective when you talk and breathe at the same time? It makes your breathing uneven, eventually draining your energy. Let’s drop the small talk.”

“You want me to shut up and just walk? No way. Huff!”

Thwack!

“Ouch! What was that for?”

“Giddyap.”

“I’ll seriously throw you off…”

Prattling and bickering like that, they used each other to mutual benefit. Javier was using Lloyd for transportation while Lloyd was using Javier as a fueling station. And the chattering worked to comfort them both.

If I was stuck down here alone, I’d have lost my marbles. Lloyd shuddered at the thought, his shoulders trembling. They were hundreds of feet below the surface. Even the fires from the explosion had dissipated. The only source of light was the glowing mushrooms that grew along the walls. If Lloyd was all alone with no one to talk to, fear would have eaten him alive. He realized later that carrying Javier piggyback had a generous payoff.

A message dinged in front of him.

Ding Dong.

[Javier Asrahan is very grateful for what you are doing for him.]

[Javier Asrahan is developing feelings of trust for you for the first time.]

[Your approval rating with Javier Asrahan has increased by six points.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: -14]

[You have earned 108 RP by improving relationships with main characters.]

[Current RP: 157]

Still carrying Javier on his back and shoulders, Lloyd glanced over his shoulder and chuckled. “You scamp, are you grateful?”

“What do you mean?”

“Never mind. Hey, I think I’m starting to see a familiar path.”

“I see it too.”

Thankfully, the path that led aboveground could be found easily. The countless battles with the giant ants left breadcrumbs; making a trail they could follow. They saw the sliced and severed body parts of the ants on the ground. Lloyd simply needed to follow the bits of dead ants. A familiar route started to appear, filling them with hope. Their hearts began to brighten. That is until they saw that the tunnel had collapsed and the path was blocked.

“Hmm.”

Lloyd wondered if the explosion caused this. He wiped the sweat off his forehead and studied the blocked path. He used the surveying skill to find out what was on the other side. But he didn’t see any open space beyond the sixteen-foot limit. This meant that he had to burrow at least sixteen feet to

make it out to the other side. *Sixteen feet? Could be 160 for all I know.* If that were the case, it'd be faster for him to find another path than to stick with this one.

Lloyd whipped around. They didn't have much time. *I gotta hurry…*

Just then.

Rumble! Rumble!

A booming sound rang out. The entire cave shook. A gust of sand blew in his direction. But instead of running away from it, he jumped into it. And there, he saw the path behind them had completely collapsed. This meant only one thing.

"Are we seriously trapped in here?"

"It appears so." He couldn't laugh it off this time. Lloyd looked down at Javier. Then he studied the collapsed path behind them. It was as thick as the one in front. He saw nothing beyond sixteen feet. *We're screwed.*

They were completely trapped. Lloyd's heart pounded. He was losing hope. The dire worst-case scenario he yearned to avoid had happened. *How long can we survive here?*

Lloyd quickly read the space he was doomed in. It was small. Barely a couple dozen square feet. They would run out of oxygen soon. *I say thirty minutes? Maybe less.*

After that, oxygen would grow scarce in the place. That meant the end for both of them. But Lloyd couldn't just stand still. He brought out Bangul and handed her to Javier.

"Can you please wake her up? Slap her or something. Okay? We need her right now."

"Will do."

Javier seemed to have understood the situation as he took the snake-like animal without any complaints.

Lloyd racked his brain for a solution. *It's a do-or-die situation. There's nowhere else to go.*

Everything would end if he gave up here. He needed to try his best, using every means possible. He had 157 RP in his hands right now, and the time had come for him to employ it to maximum effect.

Lloyd opened up his skill window.

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Chapter 27: Double Circle (2)

Lloyd was trapped inside a collapsed tunnel with only about thirty minutes of air. Now there was no going back. He opened his skill window.

[Loading skill window.]

I need to do everything I can. Lloyd's eyes moved rapidly. He selected a menu that caught his interest: "Develop Special Skills."

[Searching abilities for skill development.]

Yes, it works. Lloyd clenched his fists. He remembered the time he opened the skill window after earning some RP from Javier. He clearly recalled every word in the message that guided him through it. *There was a message that said I can spend RP to develop special skills…*

He was right. It allowed his abilities and knowledge to be turned into skills. That's how he was able to develop surveying and designing skills. They came from the civil engineering he learned in college.

There was more. He had upgraded his shoveling experience into a special skill. The long years of doing part-time jobs and shoveling until numb turned out to have benefits too. The system considered shoveling as one of his abilities and advanced it into a skill. *This means that the same thing could happen with other abilities.*

Lloyd had no doubt that the skills he needed most right now could be upgraded from the experience he already had.

Just as Lloyd wished, a new message popped up.

[Log of special skills that can be developed:

Absorbing mana from surroundings.

Processing absorbed mana.

Amplification of absorbed mana.]

[These skills can be combined into the skill “Asrahan Core Technique.”]

[RP needed for skill development = 15]

Yes! It was just as he had expected. The result could not be any better. Without hesitation, he invested fifteen RP.

Ding Dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique has been developed.]

[Skill Name: The Asrahan Core Technique.]

[Stage: Single Circle Level 5]

[The skill absorbs the mana around you. Absorbed mana is processed or amplified into the circle produced around your heart. The higher the number of circles, the higher the amplification rate.]

[Mana amplified to: 120%]

[Required RP to level up: 10]

[Current RP: 142]

Great! The result was as desired. Asrahan Core Technique was now a skill he possessed. And even better, he wasn’t starting at skill-level one. He was at level five… much higher than expected. *It’s probably because of all the practice I did.* He had trained quite hard. He had used it in an actual fight during his duel with Sir Neumann.

After that, he used every chance he had to train in the technique. It seemed his efforts were paying off. He wasn’t going to be satisfied getting just that far. *If that had been enough, I wouldn’t have to use my precious RP.* The skill didn’t improve his technique at all. The ability to absorb, process, and amplify mana makes a difference.

Now he could make more drastic changes, thanks to his technique turning into skills. *I don't have to train and practice anymore. With just some RP investment, I can make vast improvements.* That was the biggest difference. Lloyd invested more RP in the Asrahan Core Technique.

[Skill Level Up!]

[The Asrahan Core Technique: Single Circle Level 6]

[Mana amplified to: 125%]

[Required RP to level up: 15]

[Current RP: 132]

One level up and his mana was amplified by another 5 percent. *All right. Not bad.* Lloyd added the numbers in his head. Each level-up required an additional five RP over the previous one. What would happen if he exhausted all his RP? *I'd easily go over level ten for the single circle, and if my calculations are correct, I could turn that up to eleven. It's a close call, but still possible.*

It was a gamble regardless. He would fail if the system consumed more than five RP for each level up. However, he wouldn't know until he tried. Plus, he didn't have time to hesitate right now. *It's all or nothing!* Lloyd must invest all the RP he had to level up.

His Asrahan Core Technique levels soared through the roof.

From level six to seven…

From level nine to ten…

At last, after draining every last bit of RP, the message he hoped to read appeared.

Ding Dong.

[Skill Class Level Up!]

Success! Lloyd clenched his fists again. Just as he expected, one level up from level ten increased his skill class. To his great relief, he did not come up short on RP in the process. He read through the message that popped up in front of him.

[Your Asrahan Core Technique class has been increased to <Double>.]

[Skill options have been made available following your change in skill class.]

[The Asrahan Core Technique: Double Circle Level 1]

[Mana amplified to: 200%]

[Skill Option 1: Energizer - Utilizes the double circle to its maximum efficiency. Allows ten minutes of movement without fatigue. (Limit: Can only be used once per day.)]

[Skill Option 2: Latent Power Surge - Drives the amplification of the circle to the farthest limit. Mana amplification is tripled for 20 seconds. However, after one use, you will be drained of all energy, and you will not be able to use the Asrahan Core Technique for a day. (Limit: Can only be used once per day.)]

[Required RP to level up: 100]

[Current RP: 7]

Thud! Thud!

When Lloyd was almost finished reading the skill description, his heart thumped twice. A strange and powerful sensation gripped his chest.

Crackle…

The single circle he had created before floated perpendicular to a new circle he created. From the front, it looked like his heart was being wrapped in a cross. The new circle started to rotate. Z*iiing!*

“Whew!”

The two circles rotated in harmony. New energy rushed through his blood vessels, waking every single cell in his body. Lloyd sucked in a deep breath unexpectedly. He was overwhelmed by this awesomeness. A gentle smile spread across his face.

It’s done. It was amazing. He was doubtful of the explanation of skills. But now — as his body underwent a thoroughly extraordinary transformation — he realized the power of the double circle.

Up until a little while ago, he was extremely exhausted. But now he didn’t feel a trace of fatigue. In fact, his entire body had been revitalized with energy that wasn’t there earlier. This vigor and vitality were on a different level from what he felt with the single circle. *Good job, Lloyd. You modified the Asrahan Core Technique into a skill.*

Lloyd wanted to gain two things by turning the technique he had practiced into a skill.

One was rapid growth. As soon as it became a skill, he could use his RP to level up and get better. If he was lucky, he could shorten months and years of work and training to a few minutes or hours. His assumptions had been right on the mark.

Second was more skill options following the upgrade in class. Lloyd had already raised the class of survey and design skills before. He had a lot of fun at the time with the skill options he had gained. And he thought the same could happen with Asrahan Core Technique. Once the skill leveled up and reached double circle, he assumed he would be rewarded with corresponding options. This assumption proved to be correct as well.

The options were amazing. The first one transformed him into an energizer that provided him with inexhaustible power for ten minutes once a day. The second one granted him a burst of explosive power for twenty seconds. These options are extremely useful right now. *Okay, let’s try them out.*

Crack! Lloyd grabbed his steel shovel. And remembered why he spent all his RP to deal with this situation. *To clear a path and get out of here. Like this!*

Bang! His shovel flew with a sonic boom. Lloyd energetically dug through the gravel that blocked the cave entrance. He shoveled out hunks of earth with an unmatched force.

Swoosh! Thwack! Thwip! Whack! His forearms bulged from the effort.

A little more! Don't stop! The frantic shoveling stirred up a storm around the place. This was shoveling far beyond what was normally possible. He ferociously dug out huge rocks and chunks of earth, each shovelful removing a bucket-sized hole. He tore through it faster than a starving man eating his first meal in a week.

Thwack! Squash! Smack!

I'm not getting tired! This is great! Lloyd had already activated the energizer, which was the first option. It worked just as promised. He didn't tire, no matter how much he dug. No signs of sweat or heavy breathing. Despite the constant shoveling, the double circles amply retained the mana amplified around the heart. He transferred the mana into his shovel. His shoveling grew even more powerful and precise.

I shouldn't dig like an animal. This place could collapse again. The tunnel had already caved in from the methane gas blast. Any more pressure could make it crumble down again. So, even though Lloyd's shoveling was rough, it was measured. Fierce but careful. Fast but gentle.

It was all the product of his many years of shoveling. *It was a good thing that I went down to the job center whenever I needed some money.* Lloyd had been praised countless times for his shoveling. In the military. On construction sites. Back in that other world, all that experience digging was what helped him out the most right now.

That was practically my major. Moving cement around with a shovel. Most other Korean guys who were in the military or worked construction had

probably done the job before at least once. First, mix the sand and cement and stack a mound of them up. Then, hollow out a hole in the center. Pour the correct amount of water into it. Finally, you break down the mix surrounding the hole with your shovel and quickly combine it with the water. It was crucial to maintain strict shovel control and keep the water in the mix, not letting any spill outside. This was Lloyd's special shovel training. *I can't believe I'm doing this right now!*

Thwack! Crack! Whack!

He had dug into the wall of rubble countless times. The shovel moved and plunged like it was Lloyd's third hand. He adjusted the intensity and placement with precision. It was strong when he scraped and dug the earth and delicate when he scooped and skimmed. When he turned it over and stabbed, he was fast and smooth. Each movement worked in harmony. The integrity of the tunnel walls remained intact even though Lloyd excavated it at awe-stirring speed. Over a hundred feet, he kept on digging… *So, please…! Come on! Show yourself!* He was now five minutes in using the energizer skill. Lloyd bit his lip in anxiety.

Digging up a storm, he used the surveying skill at the same time. He could see fifteen feet ahead of him in the path he was making. But there was still no sign of hope.

Fifteen feet.

There was nothing but earth. Making matters worse, the air was slowly growing murky.

I won't even be able to use Bangul. There wasn't enough room for Bangul to turn gigantic. He also feared she would consume all the oxygen in the tunnel. Giving her a red seed was out of the question. Lloyd clenched his teeth.

I need to do this by myself. The future looked bleak, but he couldn't stop now. There would be nothing but despair if he did. He started digging even more relentlessly.

Thwack! Thwack! Crack! Whack! The excavation expanded. It had gone from eighteen to twenty-one feet.

Just then…

Huh? Lloyd noticed something straight ahead. It was a space as small as a fist. *Could it be…?*

Wham! Thwack! Lloyd sped up his shoveling. He advanced faster. Each time he took a step forward, the space fifteen feet ahead of him grew larger. It started at just the size of a fist. Then it grew to the size of a watermelon. Then to the size of a barrel. Finally, he could see the whole width of the passage they had drilled. *Found it!* The tunnel stood right in front of him — fully intact — just fourteen feet away.

“Javier!” Lloyd shouted. “Follow me! If you can’t walk, crawl!” His head started pounding. He started seeing double. Symptoms of hypoxia. He was running out of oxygen.

I don’t have much time. He was feeling drowsy. Soon, he would lose consciousness. He’d drift off to sleep, slowly suffocating to death. Hypoxia. Anoxia. All the air gone. Fade to black.

Every time drowsiness clawed at him to drag him down he bit his lip and moved his shovel. *A little more. Just a little more!* Just about nine feet more. He didn’t even have to dig out the entire wall. Just a small hole. As small as a fist. Big enough to let the oxygen in. That was their shot at survival.

Ding, Dong!

[Energizer has reached its ten-minute time limit.]

Ten minutes were over already. As soon as the message appeared, he lost all strength. The fatigue was devastating. A thorough assault on mind and body. *No, it can’t end here.*

There wasn’t much left. Just a little more. Even as he struggled against the drowsiness from lack of oxygen, Lloyd’s eyes suddenly flew open. *Latent Power Surge!*

Ding Dong.

[Asrahan Core Technique skill option, Latent Power Surge, has been activated.]

[Amplification of the double circle is active up to the maximum limit.]

[Mana amplification rate has been tripled for 20 seconds.]

[Mana amplified to: 600%]

Fwoosh! Thwack!

No more careful shoveling. Like a ferocious beast clawing its way out of a trap, Lloyd stabbed, scooped, scraped, and dug away the dirt in front of him. He was getting very close to the intact part of the original tunnel, which was their only way out.

Crack! Smack! Thwack! Six feet… Four feet… Three feet… Two… He forced his way forward for survival. And at last, the only obstacle that stood before him was a one-foot-wide wall of dirt.

[Latent Power Surge has reached its 20-second time limit.]

[A consequence of activating the option is complete exhaustion.]

Clunk! He suddenly became weak. The shovel slipped out of his hands. His knees buckled. He tried to force his eyes open, but it was no use.

Shit. He held out his hand to grab the shovel. *I’m almost there. It’s right in front of my eyes. I dug about thirty-six feet in ten minutes. I just need to take one more step. Is this how I die?*

Lloyd was frustrated. Lloyd was also sorry. And Lloyd felt way more wretched when he looked at Javier, who was lying sprawled out on the

ground, unconscious. *I shouldn't have dragged him into this.* A bitter smile escaped him. And sleepiness slowly crept in.

That's when he started hearing things.

"Ppodong!"

"Eh…?"

But something was off. The sound was too clear to be a hallucination. Mustering the last shred of strength he had, Lloyd lifted his head. And… *P-Pop!* That hole the size of a fist he so desperately wished for suddenly appeared in front of him. A hole made by a hamster the size of a fist, who poked his head through and said…

"Ppodong!"

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Chapter 28: Double Circle (3)

“Ppodong!”

A hole appeared in the wall in front of Lloyd. Ppodong stuck his head out of it and smiled at Lloyd, who had collapsed just in front of the wall. Lloyd called out in utter disbelief.

“Ppodong…?”

“Ppodong!”

“Is that really you?”

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong?”

Ppodong nodded eagerly and began his tale of recent events.

***

While Lloyd was engrossed in mine excavation, Ppodong had been bored to death. Since Bangul was helping out on that job, Ppodong was left with nothing to do and spent his days just goofing around in his room. He liked it at first, but the boredom started to feel wretchedly dull. After a few days, the boredom became unbearable and Ppodong walked out of Lloyd’s room to wander around the estate.

On his journey, he bumped into Lloyd’s mother, who was tending to the flowers in her garden. With a warm welcome, she said, “I’m very grateful. I was, in fact, concerned about my garden lately since some mice have been causing trouble. They must be your cousins; could you go find them? Please tell them to stop, that I would like to keep my flower garden beautiful. Can you do that, Ppodong?”

Ppodong accepted right away since he had nothing else to do anyway. Excited and bolstered by this new mission, he rushed into the grass. After Ppodong scavenged the estate and its surroundings for some time, he

spotted the group of mice and met the chief. Ppodong made what he thought was a quite decent offer to the chief.

“Ppodong? Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong?”

He proposed that the mice clan stay away from the baroness’s flower garden.

But the chief of the mice said, “Squeak! Squeak? Squeak, squeak!”

The chief did not understand Ppodong at all.

Due to the language barrier between the two of them, the deal collapsed and that triggered a war between the mice and the hamsters. It was Ppodong that waged war and bravely charged forth. Every time he saw them in the garden, he pressed and bounced and rammed the mice family.

The mice went berserk every time Ppodong laid into them, scattering in fear from the terrifying hamster. Today was unlike any other as Ppodong pursued the chief mouse, but he was proving to be faster than Ppodong expected.

The chief mouse just barely escaped Ppodong’s reach every time. Their chase led them through the flower garden, its entrance, the village, and the foot of the mountain until they ultimately found themselves in the mines. Before he knew it, Ppodong had entered the mine and had reached the ant cave.

“Ppodong?”

Ppodong didn’t know where he had ended up. Plus, he lost the mice and prepared to turn back. Ppodong would have returned home if he didn’t hear a familiar voice nearby just then.

“Hah! Whew!”

Technically speaking, it wasn’t a voice but a gasp. Still, Ppodong recognized the owner of the pained vocalization right away.

“Ppodong!”

It was the same guy who summoned him into this world and took him under his wing. It was Lloyd.

“Ppodong? Ppo-do-dong!” Ppodong had exclaimed in pure hamster joy, but Lloyd did not answer and simply panted for air somewhere nearby. His breathing was followed by the sound of shoveling.

“Ppodong?”

Ppodong cocked his head to the side and thought, *Lloyd must be digging up the ground somewhere! I can help him then!*

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!”

Standing still, Ppodong intensely studied where the sound was coming from. *Lloyd was near… He’s on the other side of where* I was *standing!*

As his little paws swiftly dug at the earth in Lloyd’s direction, his chubby little hamster butt swayed each time the wall of earth thinned down. Just as his tiny paws began to sweat, Ppdong poked his head through the wall of dirt and reached Lloyd at last.

“Is that really you?”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong casually waddled over to Lloyd and rubbed his backside against him. It was when Lloyd could even smell Ppodong’s unique hamster scent that he became convinced Ppodong was real.

“Woah, how did you end up here?” *What a pleasant surprise. I thought we were going to die in here.* The drowsiness was slowly fading away thanks to the small hole that Ppodong made, which was letting in fresh air.

The headache is still there, but… This place still lacks oxygen. Although it was better than nothing, the small hole worked only to prevent the situation from becoming a disaster. *It’s better than dying,* Lloyd thought as he

wriggled his fingers. He was grateful that they moved at all when he wanted them to.

“Hey, Ppodong? I have a favor to ask you.”

“Ppodong?”

“Can you bite my nose? I need to wake up.”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“It’s all right. That won’t kill me.”

“Ppodong?”

“I mean it. Come on.”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong climbed on Lloyd’s shoulder. He stood on his hind legs and placed his front paws against Lloyd’s cheek and promptly bit his nose.

“Ppodong!”

“Ack!”

The pain stung more than he thought it would, causing his body to shudder in response. But the pain successfully jostled him out of the numbing stupor.

“Y-yes… Th-thank you!”

Lloyd flashed a smile at Ppodong, who flashed the high-five sign back at Lloyd as he stood up on the human’s shoulders. After some struggle, Lloyd got to the wall on all fours. Once he took several gulps of air through the small hole in the wall, his mind cleared. *I need to save that guy as well.* Lloyd turned around and crawled back to Javier, who was several feet away from him.

Javier was knocked out cold b. But he was still breathing. With immense effort, Lloyd dragged him to the air hole. Grabbing him by the collar, Lloyd lifted his body and brought his face near the hole. A few seconds later, the color in his pale face returned. *Okay, time to get out.* The place seemed ready to collapse at any time. With heightened urgency, Lloyd struggled to get to his feet and picked the steel shovel up off the ground.

He could not use the Asrahan Core Technique anymore, due to the penalty imposed on him for using the surge of latent power. But he had some physical strength left in his body. He stabbed the wall with his shovel in one feeble motion. *Stab.*

The shovel merely dug into one centimeter of dirt, but that was enough. Lloyd leaned over and pressed his body against the shovel.

Thud… Pushed forward by the weight of his body, the shovel dug deeper, slowly and gradually, until the dirt wall started to give way.

Thwack! The shovel suddenly burst through. It finally penetrated the foot-thick wall. *It worked!* Lloyd flexed his muscles and leaned forward a little more. The pressure of his weight turned into a weapon.

Crash! He pushed at the wall with his shoulder and pressed against it with his entire weight. Finally, the wall crumbled.

“Whew!”

It got him covered in dirt, but he didn’t care. Air rushed into his lungs as he took another deep breath, much more than what he barely got from the tiny hole. He felt invigorated.

“Can you please open your eyes now?” Lloyd grumbled as he again carried Javier on piggyback who felt heavier now for some reason. He wondered if it was because Javier was passed out, or because of his own exhaustion. Nonetheless, Lloyd ambled toward the exit. *I need to walk slower at a time like this. My steps must be measured. No unnecessary exertion. Gird my loin and thigh. This is how you moved heavy objects when you’re tired*. Forcefully tensing your muscles would only lead to faster exhaustion. The

heavier the object, the slower you should move. The more tired you were, the more technique you needed to employ.

Back in the days when he visited the job center every morning, Lloyd carried heavy bags of cement and bricks on his back. *I even carried tiles and bricks on my back and went up and down four-story apartment units! This is nothing!* He clenched his teeth, every synapse of his mind focused on walking. The path toward the exit could be found easily as Ppodong led the way. He simply focused all his heart and mind on each step. One foot in front of the other. Soon he'd be walking out the door.

Sometime later…an unexpected message popped in front of him.

Ding Dong.

[You were able to overcome physical limitations in extreme circumstances through impressive skills of improvisation.]

[This experience is having a strong effect on your Asrahan Core Technique.]

[A new skill option has been opened.]

[Skill Option 3: Power Saving Mode—Even in extreme exhaustion, you can use the Asrahan Core Technique, albeit weakly. Mana amplification rate is fixed at 10 percent in this state.]

Eh? What now? Lloyd blinked in surprise. He had never imagined a skill option like this would be available. Its effect was felt immediately.

Zi-zing! The mana of the double circle, which was dormant due to exhaustion, started to rotate again. The rotation was at 10 percent of usual but that was enough for him. Having suffered from severe fatigue, this bit of mana was enough for him. It was like sweet rain on a dry day.

Mana is being absorbed again! The Asrahan Core Technique was automatically working again, even though he didn't will it. His body absorbed a small portion of mana around the area, causing it to rotate

around the circle and nurture various parts of his body. He was revitalized. *I can do it! I can get out!* His steps became faster and more vigorous. He walked on and on, never stopping, despite having Javier on his back.

Lloyd's surroundings began to change. The number of glowing mushrooms started to lessen. Yet the area didn't get any darker. That was because a swinging torch illuminated the path for Lloyd straight ahead of him.

"Over there! It's Master Lloyd!" Someone shouted, followed by dozens of frantic footsteps. They rushed forward to support him. The baron was among them.

"Are you fine? Are you hurt anywhere?" The baron held Lloyd's face and asked, his voice full of alarm.

Lloyd chuckled.

He wasn't in the right mind to answer the question. *I'm alive,* he thought as all the pent-up tension in his body began to release. A smile escaped him. His eyelids shut. *Hah, it's been a long day.* He used to experience this feeling when he was living in the dorms. Overwhelmed by exhaustion, he collapsed in the baron's embrace. This long, hectic ordeal was finally over.

***

Many days later.

Lloyd was still sleeping, and nobody expected that he'd sleep this long. Even after two days, he hadn't opened his eyes. He was perfectly fine, save for some over-stretched muscles and ligaments. He had no signs of sickness, either. After the doctor came to check up on Lloyd, he explained to the baron and baroness that he was simply taking a rest, as his body was suffering from severe fatigue. The baron and baroness were often in his bedroom, so as to stay beside him every moment they were free.

This was especially the case with the baron. He had not hesitated to kill the beast ants, and he led the way to clear the path that led to the underground ant nest. Although he broke his arm in the fight and suffered from a fever,

he refused to be bedridden all the time. He rushed to check up on Lloyd. The baroness was just as doting as her husband. She held down the fort while the baron recovered, taking over the responsibilities of the barony. She personally visited the soldiers injured in the fight against the ants, praised their efforts, and supported their recovery.

Meanwhile, a heartwarming rumor slowly spread across the fiefdom.

It was about Lloyd.

The rumor claimed that this formerly quite brutish young master had evacuated the workers when the giant ants appeared. He then stayed behind with Javier to keep everyone safe. As if that wasn't enough, he bravely charged into the ant nest, saving Javier in the process. Many witnesses verified the rumor. They were the evacuated workers and soldiers who saw Lloyd hobbling out with Javier on his back.

The young master had risked his life to protect the people in his lands and never gave up on his loyal knight. The men in the fiefdom raised their fists in respect, the women found their hearts fluttering as they heard of Lloyd's heroism, and the soft-hearted elders wiped tears from their eyes.

When Javier first woke up, the baron and the baroness called to him, and asked what happened down in the tunnels. As the loyal young knight related his story, the couple reacted in shock, regret, and relief.

And everyone waited, hoping sincerely that the young master would regain consciousness and return to good health.

At long last, four days after his rescue, Lloyd did wake up.

[All of Baron Frontera's subjects were deeply moved by your heroic courage and sent their praises.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of Bonus RP.]

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Chapter 29: A Favorable Plan (1)

Ding Dong.

[All of Baron Frontera's subjects were deeply moved by your heroic courage and sent their praises.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 500 RP.]

[Current RP: 507]

Lloyd blinked absentmindedly. He wondered if it was because he had slept for too long. Everything was blurry. No, technically speaking, he was seeing things. *Wait, RP? A large amount of bonus? A whopping 500 RP?* Still feeling the grogginess in his head, he read the message. Then, the events that had taken place began to come back to him.

Oh. He remembered the mine construction, the wild ants, the methane gas explosion, the rescue from the dark tunnel, and the hard, painstaking walk with Javier on his back. Everything was slowly returning to him.

I'm alive. He especially recalled the gut-wrenching walk with Javier on his back and how the baron and the group of soldiers arrived to save him. As the backstory of the RP award became clear in his head, he understood the message.

Kekeke. Everyone's praising my accomplishment, eh? This is going great. Very great.

Lloyd was satisfied. He had done his utmost to stay alive, and he managed to survive like a tenacious honeysuckle.

He was now being compensated with a hefty sum of RP. *This feels like finding a 50-dollar bill in a jacket pocket after forgetting about it the whole time. Sweet.* He fell into a happy reverie. *How should I use this? Wait, hold*

on for a second. You know what? I better save them up instead of splurging it all away. The future was uncertain and the most reliable help he could turn to in contingencies was the richly accumulated RP. He knew this from his personal experience.

What would've happened if Javier's impression of me didn't improve when I got him on my back? He wouldn't have acquired any RP. He would've wasted all his hard-earned RP by failing to turn the Asrahan Core Technique into a skill. *I'd have helplessly perished there.*

Every strand of hair on his arms stood at the thought. *Since RP is my last resort and insurance in dangerous situations, I shouldn't waste any and should save some for later.*

Lloyd shook off his jitters, then slightly turned and froze.

He spoke. "Hey, what are you doing there?"

"I am watching you, Master Lloyd."

Lloyd asked a question and Javier answered it. After that, a heavy silence fell over them.

Just like any other time, Lloyd was the one to speak first.

"No, I mean, since when were you sitting over there like a statue and watching me?"

"Well, if you are inquiring about the time, I say about three hours."

"Three hours?"

"Yes, I have been like this since I took the shift from the baron after breakfast."

"So are you saying that you've been sitting down there since you ate breakfast?"

"Yes."

“And you’ve been keeping a careful eye on me this whole morning?”

“Yes.”

“Are you a pervert?”

“No, Young Master.”

“Then what are you doing?”

“I was just nursing you, that is all,” Javier explained.

“Nurse me? How so?”

“I was prepared to call someone the moment you stopped breathing in your sleep.”

“I am joking.”

“Ha, it doesn’t sound like one.”

“You are mistaken,” Javier said.

“By the way, how are you?”

“I am doing quite okay.”

Lloyd’s gaze moved down to Javier’s ankles. A smile of satisfaction spread across Javier’s face.

“They are perfectly healed.”

“Already? How long has it been?”

“Four days,” Javier replied.

“What? You mean I was out for four days?” Lloyd’s voice grew high-pitched.

“Yes.”

“And that’s how long it took for your badly sprained ankles to heal completely?”

“Yes.”

“What? Tell me honestly. You were malingering, right?”

“What is malingering?”

“Feigning illness.”

“I have never feigned any illness. Javier retorted in confusion.

The veins in Lloyd’s temples popped out.

“Don’t lie to me. You couldn’t walk at all. You totally looked like you were about to cry. Hm? You whined, saying, ‘Master Lloyd, I cannot walk.’ Don’t you remember? You cried like a baby. Right? That’s why I personally carried you on my back. Was it all an act?”

“Of course not.”

Javier shrugged and in a cynical tone unique to Javier, he blurted,

“It is all thanks to the triple circle’s recuperative powers.”

“Recuperative powers? Triple circle?”

“Yes,” Javier answered.

“Aha. So you are saying that you heal wildly fast because of the triple circle that explodes your mana?”

“That is perfectly correct.”

“Yikes. Now you’re upsetting me. It’s so unfair. My bones ache even now as I speak.”

“Do not get upset,” Javier comforted.

“Why not?”

“Perhaps it would be comforting if you attribute your slow healing to old age.”

“Goodness, are you a rocketman or something? Stop attacking me with the truth.”

“I never attacked you. However...”

“However?”

“I want you to know that I am happy that you are awake.”

“Sure, yes. I’m happy, too, you bastard.”

A chuckle escaped Lloyd. He couldn’t help but feel relieved. The fact that he was alive and Javier was okay relieved him.

He welcomed it very much. Lloyd noticed that the feeling must be mutual for Javier.

“What a relief, really,” Lloyd said as the reality of surviving that horrid and dreadful ant cave finally sank in him.

He slowly rose from his bed feeling relieved. But he couldn’t neglect his job anymore. He had work to do.

***

Lloyd’s body healed very fast. It was the power of the double circle he’d acquired underground. All day long, he used the Asrahan Core Technique whenever he had the chance. He amplified the mana he absorbed with two circles and had it rotate around every part of his body.

The bio-cycle of his somatic cells quickened and so did their recovery period. Within ten days or less, Lloyd’s badly sprained muscles and

ligaments had almost completely healed.

On top of his fast healing, there was more good news. The orange foreclosure notices Lloyd saw the first time he arrived in this world were gone now, bugging him no more.

The baron estate was no longer a foreclosed property. *It's all thanks to me.* Lloyd recalled the story in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* If things happened according to the novel, the baron's estate should have been completely empty now because of the early foreclosure.

However, the seizures had been canceled instead. He had worked hard to grow a heated flooring business, and it granted him the money to pay off the interest debt.

I was also able to recover the credit of the barony. What a huge relief. In the novel, the family members of the baron get evicted from the property around this time. The baron and baroness spend days in stupor and despair while Lloyd's drinking streak gets worse to the point that it spins out of control.

None of that was true anymore. The unfair tragedy was being rewritten by Lloyd himself.

So, Lloyd resolved to keep changing the future.

"So move! Stop lazing around because it's getting hot."

Lloyd's voice boomed aloud on the construction site. Time had flown by, and he was already wrapping up the mine construction project. With a tool belt hanging on his waist, he took charge and commanded the workers.

He always oversaw any hard and dangerous jobs. The artisans and civil engineer soldiers put their noses to the grindstone with more zeal and sweated heavily without any complaint.

Now trusting Lloyd all the more, they thought to themselves, *The young master puts our lives and safety before his.* The foolish little boy they knew

was long gone. His past no longer mattered to them. What mattered more was that Lloyd had stayed behind to make sure everyone evacuated safely on the day the wild ants appeared. His sacrifice and devotion left a huge impression on their hearts. Thus, they thought to themselves that such selflessness wasn't a common trait. They could trust someone like him to lead them.

He would be there to protect them even if they fell into danger again. Trust was a powerful thing. Thanks to it, there was an air of vitality in the site.

"Okay, this is the last reinforcement pillar! A little more! Okay, on three! Two! Three!"

"Argh!"

The final stage of construction came to an end at Lloyd's command. The coal mine was completed at last. However, Lloyd wasn't excited about it. He knew that this was just the start. During the dinner celebrating the construction and during the moment he handed a large bonus to everyone, he didn't get their elated emotions to carry him away.

Instead, he calmly thought about his next steps and put them into action.

Don't rush. One step at a time. Now that construction came to an end, it was time to go through safety checks. *I have to grind away to pay off the debt!* It went without saying that he needed to work hard. The baron's estate had only managed to avoid foreclosure at this time. The money he earned from the heated flooring system was just barely enough to cover the monthly interest.

And I still have the principal debt to pay off. The principal, not the interest, burdened Lloyd very much. He couldn't afford to take any breaks to pay off everything. But at the same time, he couldn't be hasty.

Safety first. Safety above all, In truth, he could simply open up the mine right now if he just wanted to pay off the debt as soon as possible. Recruit miners and educate them — the process behind it was simple. He could start mining for coal right away. Opening now without a thorough safety

check would save time and money. However, Lloyd wasn’t interested in the short-term profit.

Sure, I can make some easy money by doing that. However, considering the long-term prospects is especially important for these kinds of projects.

He recalled the countless events he had gone through back when he was in South Korea.

South Korea was a fast-paced country. He couldn’t even dream of having things like safety inspections. Heck, workers were treated like disposable objects. Factories, warehouses, and construction sites...Everywhere was the same.

People get their hands cut in the machines. They fall into the furnace and get electrocuted by the high-voltage wire. Get stuck in a screen door on the train. Boom. Accident. Fix an escalator, and you find a worker sucked into the belt...Tragic accidents make news, and the supervisors and managers make fake promises of more vigilance and shed some tears of guilt. That’s all. Everything’s back to square one once the camera is off. And they fill the empty positions left behind after an accident with new workers. They make them work until someone gets injured again. They don’t care if there’s another accident because they see the workers as replaceable. There’s nothing strange about this. It’s just a tradition. Out with the old and in with the new. Easy and convenient.

It was the dark side of society he painfully felt as he watched the news and lived in poverty,

Such tradition sickened Lloyd to the core. It even bordered on abhorrence. *Opening up the mine may make me happy now, but in the long run, I’ll lose the trust of the workers. No one’s going to do a job I give them afterward.* On top of that, if an accident occurred the costs for repair would be high. Most importantly, he didn’t like that people would be exposed to such dangers under his management. Therefore, it was necessary to perform a safety check before opening the mine. *At least I have the surveying skill with me. It’s very handy. Survey!*

Crackle! Lloyd's eyes faintly shone as he meticulously studied the mine. Lloyd meticulously inspected the internal composition and structure of the mine. He checked to see if the geographical composition was stable, the foundation was well-placed, and there weren't any signs of subsidence.

He made a great effort to make sure he scanned every inch of the ground. Once he was done with the mine, he decided to go further in.

"Please do not tell me you will be going into the ant cave again."

The coalbed that rested at the bottom of the mine—Lloyd was making his way there through an opening when Javier asked a question from behind. Lloyd chuckled as he looked back at Javier.

"Yeah, are you scared?"

"No, Young Master. I am curious why you are going in there." However..."

"However?"

"Curious? Why, it's for the safety check."

Lloyd's impassive voice implied that Javier was asking the obvious question.

"The mine we constructed is safer than this place. Sure, everyone knows ants built impressive tunnels, but there was still an explosion here. The foundation was probably weakened. And a large collapse could affect our mine higher up the ground."

Lloyd continued to explain.

"There's more. I need to inspect if there are any leftover methane gas leaks or wild ants that survived wandering around. They could come up and attack the miners. That answers your question, right? Then let's go."

After that, Lloyd entered the ant cave with Javier.

"I still do not understand."

“Really? What part?”

“Why are you risking your own life?”

“You mean why don’t I just assign someone else for the job?”

“Yes.”

Javier tilted his head to the side and said, “I have never heard of any aristocrat personally doing these dangerous jobs.”

“Is it bad for such an aristocrat to exist?”

“Excuse me?”

“I’m just checking to make sure that everything’s safe for my people. Is it that weird?”

“That’s not what I meant. It is reckless but outstanding.”

“Oh, dang. It’s not every day I get a compliment from you.”

“Please be reminded that I said ‘reckless’ before praising you.”

“Don’t be shy. Just compliment me if you want to.”

“No, thank you.”

“Haha, you’re getting soft now.”

“Soft? What is that now?”

“Nothing. Hold on. What’s that over there?”

Their bickering, which took place as they examined the ant cave, came to a halt. Squinting his eyes, Lloyd held out his torch to see what lay straight ahead. Something glimmered on the floor.

“I will check it,” Javier said as he drew his sword and moved forward.

He inspected the area Lloyd pointed out. The glimmering object turned out to be...

“A sword,” Javier announced.

“A sword?”

“Yes.”

Javier picked up the weapon.

“It is not used by humans. It is shoddy and unbalanced. Given the shape of its hilt and damaged shape...I say this belongs to an orc.”

“An orc?” Lloyd repeated in disbelief.

“Yes.”

“What’s an orc’s sword doing here?”

“I am in the dark about that.”

Lloyd was confused. He recalled orcs with pig heads occasionally appearing in *The Knight of Blood and Iron*. It was a shock to see an orc’s sword was found hundreds and thousands of feet away from the ground.

“Don’t they live in the wilderness across the eastern mountain range?”

“Yes, they do.”

“Hmm...Interesting.”

It could be that an ant just dragged it down here. Thinking that in his head, Lloyd put his worries aside.

“If we keep looking, something might turn up. Let’s get moving,” Lloyd urged.

“Understood.”

With that, they resumed their inspection. The cave was vast and complex. 15 days passed by in a flash as they meticulously studied the cave. On the 16th day...They came across a young orc warrior lying inside storage at the bottom of the ant cave.

“What is this?”

What’s an orc doing here? Dazed, Lloyd studied the orc. Javier was doing the same when he said, “It appears that this one has been captured by the ants. But it seems like he is breathing.”

“What?!” Javier exclaimed in disbelief. “It’s alive? Like a frozen person?”

Javier nodded his head.

“I believe he’s been poisoned.”

Just then, Lloyd recalled the story about the wild ants in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.*

Yes, right. The wild ants tend to store a portion of their food by paralyzing them alive.

That must have been what happened to the orc, Lloyd thought. Once he confirmed the truth, a new idea dawned on him.

“Hold on...Bingo.”

Just as soon as he checked the orc’s state, Lloyd came up with a surprisingly good plan.

A smile of contentment spread across Lloyd’s face.

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Chapter 30: A Favorable Plan (2)

“My name is Arosh. I am the thirtieth fortieth fifth descendant of Akash the Great, oink!”

“Thirtieth fortieth fifth descendant?”

“Yes, oink.”

“Do you mean thirty plus forty plus five?”

“No. Forty minus thirty plus five, oink!”

“So you’re the fifteenth descendant, yeah?’

“You calculated that in the blink of an eye. You are a genius, oink!”

Phew. With mixed feelings, Lloyd stared at Arosh, who had just woken up. He thought to himself, *Maybe I picked up a fool who doesn’t have a frontal lobe. Or it could be that this orc has only fifteen wrinkles in his brain.*

Just then, he recalled the event that happened earlier in the morning. He was exploring the ant cave with Javier, and they were in the last stage of the safety check, which had taken over 16 days to complete.

At last, they arrived at the deepest part of the ant cave, the storage where they found this orc. Surprisingly, he was alive.

“I feel shaky and numb because I slept for a long time. The ant’s paralysis poison hurts too much, oink.”

“Paralysis poison?”

“Yes, oink.”

“Of course, I knew it was paralysis poison.”

Things were starting to piece together in his head. Arosh was stored in a state of suspended animation. The purpose of keeping him alive was obvious. *The ants must have stored him here as a source of food by using the paralysis poison.* The best way to keep the food fresh was to keep it alive because livestock never spoiled or rotted. Arosh smiled, his sharp fangs sticking out of his mouth.

“My name is Arosh the Reckless. I cannot die when I have not gone through the coming-of-age ceremony, oink.”

“Coming-of-age ceremony?”

“Yes, oink.”

“So you’re a minor?”

“What’s a minor, oink?”

“Minor is...when you’re not an adult yet.”

“I will be accepted as a warrior orc after the coming-of-age ceremony. That’s why I charged into the wild ants’ territory, oink.”

“Wait, your coming-of-age ceremony involves hunting a wild ant?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes, oink.”

Arosh continued to explain.

“It is a tradition that was passed down from our great ancestors. That is, it first started when my grandfather’s father’s father settled in the eastern wilderness, oink.”

“Just say he’s your great-great-grandfather...”

“Anyway, I hunted a lot of wild ants. I punched, slashed, and killed them. I killed ten of them at once ten times. But I got too excited, oink.”

“So?” Lloyd asked.

“I wanted to become the greatest warrior after killing the queen ant. So I headed into the ant cave, oink.”

“You rushed to the ant cave? On purpose? Alone?”

“Of course. A warrior fears not being alone, oink.”

“You’re nuts.”

The story made it clear to Lloyd how this orc ended up in the ants and became a lump of juicy meat. He got carried away by the adrenaline rush and threw himself into the ants. He fought until the ants circled around and wore him out. Eventually, the poison paralyzed him.

Lloyd chuckled. We have good luck. Both the orc that got rescued and me who rescued him.

He called to mind the event that took place here a while ago. As soon as Lloyd confirmed that the orc was alive, he carried the orc into his room. The estate went berserk as a result.

The maids, who saw the orc for the first time, almost blacked out in fear. The baron rushed into Lloyd’s room as soon as he heard the news. Still donned in pajamas, the baron’s face turned pale as a sheet.

“Lloyd, what are you doing?”

“I’m inheriting the throne...No, as you can see, I brought an orc here.”

“Yes, but why?”

“Because I have a plan in mind. First, take a glass of cold water.”

Lloyd responded calmly to ensure that the baron would relax.

“I found him while I was exploring the ant cave. Saving this orc would be greatly beneficial to the fiefdom someday.”

“Beneficial? What do you mean?”

“As far as my knowledge allows, orcs are brave warriors, and they’re very strict when it comes to returning the favors and exacting revenge.”

It was true. Lloyd knew because he had read it in *The Knight of Blood and Iron* several times.

“I have heard of their character very well. But still, is this a good idea?”

“Yes. Even if this orc wakes up and throws a massive fit, Javier can easily subdue him.”

It took quite an effort for Lloyd to convince the baron that everything would be all right.

Lloyd laid Arosh on the bed and called the physician. Thankfully, the doctor came up with the diagnosis right away.

“Hmm...Given his blue nails, he must have been poisoned by the wild ants to be stored away to be eaten later. Give him this, and he will awake soon.”

“What is this?”

“The powder is made of dried and grounded tanaria leaves. It’s perfect for treating paralysis.”

Lloyd gave the orc the medicine. The physician was right. It worked very well. Within ten minutes of taking the medicine, Arosh stirred awake and opened his eyes.

“Anyway, thank you. If you didn’t take me out of there, I could have been eaten by the ants, oink.”

“Right? You’re thankful, right?”

“Yes, you are my lifesaver, oink.”

“Then you should return the favor for saving your life, right?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, oink!”

“So is this the time for me to say what I want?”

He’s falling for it. Lloyd’s voice turned sly and Arosh nodded enthusiastically.

“Of course. Anything you want, human! Oink!”

“I need about 120 male orcs who can work in the mine for us.”

Lloyd cut to the chase right away as if he had been waiting for the moment. He didn’t beat around the bush. This was the reason why he saved Arosh in the first place.

Orcs were strong as they had great stamina and were powerful. Since they were brave and bold, they didn’t fear jumping into dangerous situations. In short, orcs were as good as dwarfs when it came to tiresome mine work.

This is why I saved you. Why do you think I’d carry you all the way here if it weren’t for that?

He saved the orc for that reason and to make the orc indebted. Lloyd spoke of what he wanted but against his expectations, Arosh looked suspicious. He even avoided Lloyd’s gaze.

“Hey?” Lloyd asked.

“I thought you wanted me to say anything I want.”

Lloyd tilted his head in confusion with a nonchalant expression. Arosh avoided Lloyd’s gaze again by rolling his eyes to the side.

“Mister?”

“Mister Orc, will you please look me in the eyes?”

“Oink. That is...difficult, oink?”

“Difficult? What is?”

“Human, I am thankful for being saved. I will do anything to return the favor. But what you asked for just now is of a different nature, *oink*.”

“How is it different?”

“You’re not a warrior, oink.”

“So?” Lloyd asked.

“Anyone who is not a warrior cannot make orders to orcs. You are not qualified to do that, oink.”

Arosh’s face was filled with embarrassment to the point that he started to get flushed. With his whole heart, Arosh said, “I am sorry, human. I don’t think I can answer your request, oink.”

He was sincere. Arosh knew that this human named Lloyd had saved his life. He could have ended up as a piece of meat to the wild ants, but he saw the light of the day thanks to the human. He wanted to pay him back and wanted to give anything he asked for. Orc warriors didn’t hesitate to sacrifice their life to return a favor. This was their dignity and honor, so Arosh’s heart swelled with regret. He wanted to give what Lloyd wanted, but it was out of his control.

“Wait, do you mean that I cannot command your brothers because I’m not a warrior?”

“Yes, oink.”

“What do I have to do to get accepted as a warrior from your people?”

“You must go through a coming-of-age ceremony. The same one as us. Your accomplishments also need to be recognized by the chief, oink.”

“Really?”

A smile spread across Lloyd’s face. Raising his chin, he asked, “I think I am qualified.”

“What, oink?”

“Yeah. The coming-of-age ceremony? It’s about hunting the wild ants, no?”

“Yes, oink.”

“Well, then, can you look at that first?” Lloyd spoke as he lifted his hand.

He pointed at a corner of the room with his thumb, and Arosh moved his gaze. From Lloyd’s shoulder to the bedside wall...His gaze finally arrived at the wall. An item was hanging there.

“It’s the head of the queen. I thought I should hang it on the wall as a trophy. How is that?”

“Oink...?”

Arosh’s mouth hung wide open in surprise. The head hanging on the wall belonged to the queen.It wasn’t fake. His tribe had battled against wild ants since the beginning of their existence. There was no way he wouldn’t recognize them, let alone the queen ant!

“How did you, oink?”

“What do you mean, how? I hunted and hung it there.”

Lloyd lightly grinned as what he said was half true and half false. He did kill the queen by using the methane gas explosion, but he technically didn’t kill it after fighting it firsthand.

Lloyd flicked his lips several times. Putting on a thick face, he said, “But you see...There’s something interesting about how I killed it. Do you know what it is?”

“What is it, oink?”

“The queen didn’t have much strength left in her when I fought her.”

Lloyd’s voice turned sly.

“It was worn out as if she had already fought someone else. That’s when I came across a sword in the area. Javier?”

Lloyd turned around and Javier, who was standing still behind Lloyd, silently held up a sword. It was the sword they had found while investigating the ant cave. Arosh’s eyes widened in surprise.

“Oink? That’s my sword, oink?”

“Right? I knew it.”

Lloyd smiled meaningfully.

“Now, things are starting to come together in my head. Can you guess who drained the queen before fighting me?”

“Is it me, oink?”

“Yes, that’s it. You’re smart.”

Lloyd brightly smiled. Of course, Lloyd was lying through his teeth. The sword was discovered in an area with zero relevance to the queen, but the truth hardly mattered here.

What matters is for him to believe it. He lied because he wanted to make this deal successful. Making a deal with the orc was all that mattered to Lloyd. However, it didn’t mean that he was free from criticism. Lloyd endured Javier's piercing and judgmental gaze, branding him as a swindler.

But once again, it didn’t matter.

“Think for a second. Did you see any ant that was unusually larger than the others?” Lloyd asked.

“Oink...Argh...”

“I suppose you didn’t have the time to take a good look at them because you were too focused on fighting, no?”

“Yes, oink.”

“Let me tell you, there was a big one. Here’s the proof.”

Lloyd took the knife from Javier and handed it to Arosh.

“Here, this sword is the proof. The queen ant was drained because of you.”

“So what are you saying, human? Oink.”

“Why, I am saying that I cannot take the full credit for catching the queen.”

“Wait a minute, oink?”

“Yes, yes. We hunted it together. The queen ant died. In your hands and mine. We caught her.”

“Joint effort. Joint production. Joint copyright. Whew, these are such beautiful words. Aren’t they?”

“Then...Oink.”

“Let’s just say we killed it together,” Lloyd announced, his words as sharp as a nail.

“Technically speaking, you failed the coming-of-age ceremony. After all, you didn’t make it to the village on time. You can return now, but they’ll treat you like a loser. You know that, right?”

“Oink?”

“But just imagine right now you holding this giant head as you enter the village. Can you picture it?”

“Awesome, no?”

Gulp. Arosh loudly swallowed. Just thinking about it excited him. Countless orcs went through the coming-of-age ceremony, but no one had ever caught the queen before. So, if he arrived at the village with her head in his hand, he would make history and get the attention of all the lady orcs.

Not only that, he would be respected by all of the orc warriors. Lloyd continued to speak. He said just the right words. It was as if his words were scratching the itchy areas in the orc's body.

"Think about it. What's there to lose? And we're not tricking anyone. It's just a fact. I wouldn't have gotten the queen if it weren't for you. Right?"

"So...Oink."

"Yes, so stand up straight. You're one impressive orc."

"Oink!"

"Great. Look at you. That's better. So, can you do what I asked?"

"What you asked? Oink?"

"Hey, we teamed up to hunt that queen ant down. So what you need to do is for you to take me to your village and get me approved by your chief. Once that's through, send me one hundred and twenty orcs to our fiefdom."

"And I would...Oink..."

"You would be the warrior who passed the coming-of-age ceremony with flying colors. And what's even better is that you can return the favor you owe me. Everyone will be happy. How do you like that?"

Arosh stared at Lloyd. This human was grinning at him, had saved him from dying, and had eyes that looked kind and gentle. He was also making a suggestion Arosh was so grateful for.

Arosh decided what he must do.

“Okay, human! I am a warrior who never thinks lightly of someone’s kindness. I will do my best so you can earn the warrior title, oink!”

Arosh, young and naive, held out his thick and chubby hands. Lloyd took it and gave a hard shake. Of course, Arosh didn’t know anything. He didn’t notice the agitated smile of the man behind Lloyd. He never imagined that Lloyd was gently smiling because he was able to scam this gigantic buffoon. Just like that, Lloyd’s plan to hire the best miners to work for free in the newly completed mine was drawing close.

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Chapter 31: Muscle Loss Prevention Facility (1)

“Father, oink!”

Sprint! Arosh marched toward his father, and his worm-like veins wriggled with each step he took. The ground shook as his muscular legs, which were as thick as a lamp post, hit the floor. Lloyd was reminded of a wild hog in Ural Mountain as he watched the big orc run toward his father at an unbelievable speed. Then, Arosh was received by a fiercer and larger orc.

“Son, oink!”

Stomp! Stomp! Stomp! A middle-aged orc ran in his direction. The older orc boasted veins bigger than Arosh’s. His were as thick as snakes and his legs were as thick as utility poles. The ground shook more violently as he ran. His physique was as large as a Russian bear and so, a tiny sandstorm was created around him as he ran toward his son. The two didn’t stop until their bodies collided violently. *Crash!*

When Lloyd saw the two muscular giants tightly hug each other, he felt sorry for the air particles that were stuck in between them. While Lloyd was looking at them with distaste, the father and son were having a moment as they embraced one another.

“My boy, Arosh! Oink!”

“Father! Oiiink!”

“Are you okay, oink?!”

“I am fine! Waa, oink!!”

“What a relief. But don’t cry, son, oink.”

“Even right now, father, oink?”

“Of course. I fear you will lose more muscle by crying when you have already gotten smaller, oink!!”

“Muscle atrophy, oink!”

“A warrior never lets that happen to his body, right, my son? Oink.”

“Father, you are indeed wise, oink!”

Wise? More like his head is made of dumbbells. Lloyd let out a sigh. He watched the orcs catching up with one another. They were so muscular that Lloyd was sure that they could easily do bench presses, squats, and deadlifts with one-ton weights as a light warm-up.

They were obsessed with muscle. Even right now, their conversation revolved around building up muscle mass. Lloyd remembered how *The Knight of Blood and Iron* described the orcs as muscular fools. The author was right for calling them that. He scoffed. The sight of the two orcs called to mind the event that had taken place fifteen days ago.

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“Are you sure the plan will work?”

“Yes, probably.”

Lloyd nodded his head. He lifted the kettle and poured the fresh tea into the baron’s cup.

“Just like I have told you, Arosh trusts me completely. He considers me his lifesaver. And I heard that he is the son of a tribal chief.”

“A son? Of a tribe chief?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd spoke as he held up his teacup. He brought it to his mouth and took a sip.

“The chief will likely acknowledge his son’s accomplishment.”

“Because of the queen ant’s head...” the baron said.

“Yes, and I’ll just be freeloading.”

Joint effort and Joint hunting. Lloyd planned on throwing around some fancy words to win the chief’s heart. He would explain that he and Arosh hunted the queen ant together. That was his plan to be acknowledged by the chief, so he could be considered a warrior.

“But do you think the chief would acknowledge you so easily?” the baron asked in doubt.

“It won’t be easy. But it’s worth a try. The potential gain is too big not to try.”

It was true. The acknowledgment from the chief meant that Lloyd would obtain one hundred and twenty orcs as mine workers. One hundred and twenty brave and robust orcs would excavate the coal without getting tired. The group of orcs would be more productive than a thousand human miners.

“Plus, we’re saving the labor fee by hiring them. We simply have to shoulder their lodging and meals. It means we can use highly trained and strong laborers for free.”

“But don’t you think this is too dangerous? I do not think it is best for you to personally go to the orc village...”

“I am fine. Arosh is the son of a tribal chief, and I am his savior.”

“Hmm...”

The baron’s nose crinkled. He didn’t like that Lloyd was taking a risk. After all, the orcs were notorious for being violent and rough. So, setting his foot in their land didn’t sound very appealing. The baron wanted to do everything he could to stop Lloyd. That led to a series of more exchanges

between them, each trying to persuade the other. It was a battle of persistence. Of course, in the end, Lloyd won.

“Fine...But on one condition,” the baron said.

“What is it?”

“Take about 30 soldiers with you.”

The baron explained that he would feel relieved if Lloyd took at least thirty men with him.

Lloyd accepted the terms and he would be guarded by thirty soldiers. They were a reliable backup plan should things go awry.

“Yes. On top of the thirty civil engineer soldiers, I will have Sir Asrahan to join me as well.”

So, the preparation for their departure began. He packed up camping supplies and food. The following morning, Lloyd was ready to leave. The baron and baroness walked them out of the estate. They were sincerely worried about their son, and Lloyd felt apologetic. The realization dawned upon him that, had events unfolded as depicted in the novel, they would have already faced imminent danger, with death lurking nearby.

“I’ll leave now.”

Lloyd bid farewell, his heart feeling a bit heavy. He then turned around and left the estate.

He crossed over the eastern mountain range with his men. Arosh was a competent warrior and guide. He guided his human companions very well, for he knew all the corners of the mountains. Thanks to him, Lloyd and his men could avoid bumping into dangerous monsters. With that, they finally arrived at the orc village ten days later.

And at last...

“Oink! Nice to meet you! I, Akush, am the father of Arosh! Oink!”

Lloyd shook hands with the tribal chief as hundreds of orcs watched the human and orc handshake.

“Yes, it’s a pleasure to meet you.”

“Arosh told me that you saved my son, oink.”

“Yes, somehow.”

“Great! That makes you my savior as well, oink!”

“At the same time, your son and I hunted the queen ant.”

“What, oink?”

Akush cocked his head to the side. Lloyd glanced at Javier, and he revealed the stuff he was carrying on his back. It was as large as a gym ball. He opened it and a large and dark chunk of something appeared.

“It’s the head of the queen. I got it as a souvenir.”

“Oink?”

Akush’s eyes widened in disbelief, and his mouth slightly hung open. Chief Akush wasn’t the only one surprised. It was the same for hundreds of orcs that had surrounded them.

“Oink?! What is it, oink?!”

“Oink! I have never seen a wild ant’s head as big as that!”

“It looks fierce, oink!”

“It looks strong, oink!”

“It looks delicious, oink!”

“It sure looks tasty, oink!”

In short, the orc village was put in awe and descended into chaos. *It's time*. Lloyd told himself. He couldn't miss this opportunity. He couldn't give the orcs the time to make a proper decision. It was time for him to push, so he could get the upper hand here. So, Lloyd quickly cut in, saying, "I was exploring the cave of the wild ants when I bumped into the queen, all tired and staggering. After some struggle, I was able to finish her. But you know what? I found a metal sword near the ant."

"Orc's metal sword? Oink?"

"Yes. Your son's sword."

After saying that, Lloyd glanced at Arosh and hinted that it was time for him to talk. Arosh exhaled through his nose.

"What my savior said is correct, oink!"

"So, son, are you saying that you weakened the queen ant, and the savior finished her off, oink?"

"Yes, oink. So we fought together, oink!"

"Hmm...Oink..."

The chief Akush's eyebrows crinkled. His dark green eyes moved from his son and Lloyd to the ant head. The ant head surely belonged to the queen. It was a no-brainer for Akush. *It really is the queen.* He had spent his entire life battling wild ants. He knew more than anyone else how powerful and mighty the queen was. So it was quite a shock for him to hear that his son hunted down that great foe. The chief's thick pecs trembled in admiration.

"Son, oink!"

"Yes, oink!"

"Congratulations! You're now a warrior! I, tribal chief Akush, declare that Arosh earned the rightful title of a warrior! Oink!"

"Thank you, oink!"

“Great! This calls for a celebration. Time to work out the legs! Oink!”

“ A man is nothing without his legs, oink!”

As soon as Akush ordered, Arosh ran to a side of the village. Once there, he lifted a large statue and tossed it on his shoulders. It was not just large, it was huge, probably weighing around 2,000 pounds. Even more, it was gilded in gold. Aside from the expensive statue, the place was littered with luxurious goods, and they were only used as workout tools.

A chandelier was being used as plates. The bar in the middle was a pillar adorned with expensive pearls. The chest full of treasures was being used as a kettlebell! *Wow, incredible.*

Lloyd recalled how capable the orcs were at pilfering and battling. It was described as so in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* However, in reality, they stole much more. *It must be the loot they have been stealing for decades. But those riches mean nothing to these orcs. Tsk.*

The riches and treasures got downgraded to workout instruments. Arosh was doing squats with a gold statue. Lloyd’s heart swelled with greed as he surveyed the place. Meanwhile, Arosh heavily exhaled through his nose as he carried the statue. He squatted up and down, and his anaconda-like thigh muscles bulged. Akush’s face brightened with a smile as he looked at his son.

“Just look at him. What a splendid day, oink.”

Akush then turned to Lloyd’s side. He hand-gripped Lloyd’s shoulder. His hand was as big as a frying pan.

“Thank you, human. You not only saved my son but proved your courage by hunting the queen ant, oink.”

“Do you mean that I’m going to be a warrior as well?” Lloyd asked.

Sometimes, one needed to be brazen. Some questions needed to be asked as bluntly as possible. Akush happily nodded.

“Of course! I, Tribal Chief Akush, declare that...Oink?”

“It’s Lloyd. Lloyd Frontera..”

“I appoint the human, Lloyd Frontera, as a rightful warrior of the tribe, oink!”

Finally, Akush announced the birth of a new warrior. Hundreds of orcs exclaimed in joy. In an exceedingly nonchalant manner, Akush shouted, “The human lifesaver has become a warrior! This is leg day for him, too, oink!”

“Excuse me...?”

Hold on. This muscle man said what? He can’t seriously expect me to squat with that statue on my back. Lloyd swallowed absentmindedly, but his gut feelings, especially the bad ones, were always right. Chief Akush smiled widely as he slammed Lloyd’s back.

“Let’s go! I am feeling good today. I shall do it together with you, oink!”

“ A man is nothing without his legs, oink!”

Dear heavens...He was in despair as the shouts around him were growing larger and more excited. Lloyd’s anxiety and embarrassment grew just as much.

“Excuse me.”

“Oink?”

“I like working out and lifting heavy stuff, but that’s just...” Lloyd trailed off.

“Oink?! What do you mean, oink?”

“That is too heavy for me.”

Lloyd came clean on this one. It was true. Though Lloyd was quite confident when it came to lifting heavy stuff with all the extra power the Asrahan Core Technique gave him, he wasn't strong enough to carry a despairingly heavy statue and squat with a smile on his face.

"Thank you for the workout offer, but do you think you have anything lighter?"

He wanted to protect his waist and legs, so he asked. Akush's expression darkened.

"What? You can't carry that, oink?"

"No," Lloyd answered.

"Even when you're a warrior, oink?"

"Surely..."

"It cannot be! But you are a warrior, oink!"

"It is one of the lightest tools in the village. It is a warm-up tool for young warriors. So if you can't lift that, you don't deserve to be a warrior, oink."

"But I am not an orc."

"But you are a warrior, oink."

Akush's face was growing solemn each second. Lloyd's expression was hardening as well.

Dammit. Things were going smoothly for him. Lloyd never expected his plan would be obstructed by something as absurd as squatting. So he racked his brain for a solution.

It's all gone if I tell him that I can't squat. What should I do?

He had come too far now to give up. The benefit of earning the title of warrior was too great as it allowed for gratuitous access to one hundred and

twenty strong orc miners. He didn’t wish to give up easily, but at the same time, he didn’t like the idea of breaking his back from lifting that heavy thing up even more.

I need something else. He needed to win over the chief’s heart with something else other than the squat. He needed to use something he was good at. That’s all it took for him to get approved by them. Lloyd rapidly moved his eyes. He surveyed every corner of the village, its environment, lifestyle, and anything he could lay his eyes on. After much classifying and analyzing, he realized that something oddly stood out in the village. *Hold on.* He stared at a hole made in the corner of the village.

“What is that?” Lloyd asked as he pointed at the hole.

Akush answered, “That? A hole for throwing meat away, oink.”

“Throw meat away?”

“Yes, we toss them there and bury them in soil, oink.”

Akush nodded.

“We throw away the spoiled meat. They can give you an upset stomach if you aren’t careful. If you get sick, you can’t work out. No workout means muscle loss, oink.”

The chief’s voice contained a tinge of regret.

“It is a regretful thing. If we could eat everything, we could build even more muscle. I never feel good throwing it all away, oink.”

“Is that so?”

“That’s right, oink.”

Akush licked his lips and the corners of Lloyd’s lips rose. *This is it.* Just then, Lloyd recalled the middle of *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* In the later part of the story, Javier goes out on an adventure and winds up in a battle with the orc tribe all alone.

The battle proved to be tough. But his clever trick finally gets him to defeat this muscular tribe. The trick was disrupting the orcs' hunting. *This wilderness is barren. Farming is impossible, and foraging won't be enough to procure a sufficient food supply. So they heavily rely on hunting. Almost all of the food among the orcs are acquired through hunting.*

They put food on their tables by hunting large and menacing monsters in the wilderness.

That was why they had to be so brave and courageous. However, they didn't have a way to store their hard-earned food. They simply threw their food in a pile and ate. That's why even freshly caught food spoiled easily. *Javier sees through that weakness and interferes with the orc's hunting. In less than ten days, the orc village experienced a food shortage.* They had no system to store and preserve food and with Javier's interruption, the orcs failed to even procure new meat. That eventually leads to a food shortage. Lloyd recalled such a part in the novel.

"I have a suggestion," Lloyd said.

"Suggestion, oink?"

"No," Lloyd answered.

He looked up at Akush.

"Instead of the leg workout, I will build cold storage for your people. Approve me then as your warrior."

Then, pay us back with your overflowing gold and silver. This way, Lloyd would be accepted as a warrior, and he could take the orc workers with him. While he was at it, he'd also sign a contract with Akush and demand payment for the construction.

He would kill two birds with one stone and fill two needs with one deed or carry two faces under one hood. After finishing the calculation in his head, Lloyd smiled mischievously.

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Chapter 32: Muscle Loss Prevention Facility (2)

“Yeah, we’re making a *seokbinggo*.”

Whoosh. The wind blew in the wilderness and sand particles assaulted Lloyd’s eyes. Lloyd squinted his eyes and looked around the empty lot with a small slope.

“What is that?”

Just as Lloyd expected, Javier asked what it was. Lloyd scoffed.

“Bingo.”

“Pardon?” Javier asked.

“No, never mind. Have you ever heard of an ice house?”

“I never have.”

“I’m sure you haven’t.”

Seokbinggo, otherwise known as an ice house. These facilities had been used in the past to store ice during the hot season. Seokbinggo was used in Korea during the Joseon Dynasty, while the latter was used in ancient Europe. The Yazd region in the Middle East had one of those, too. Its name was *moayedi*, and that ice storage facility could still be found in recent times. In short, such facilities were used everywhere in the world throughout history,

However, it was different for the Laurasia continent, where *The Knight of Blood and Iron* was set.

*The continent doesn’t have it because of magic.*In this world, ice was a luxury only sought after by wealthy aristocrats during the summer and some mages happily stepped forward to serve the rich. Mages always stood by to immediately summon a glass of iced sangria in the scorching summer.

“So, I’m thinking of constructing that for the first time in this continent’s history.”

“For the orcs?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded his head.

This sloped land appeared perfect for a seokbinggo. In his head, Lloyd calculated the population of the orc village and the average amount of food they ate and hunted. He then measured the dimension of the seokbinggo accordingly. *This one should definitely be bigger than the one built during the Joseon Dynasty.* As Lloyd used his surveying and measuring skills, he recalled the event that had taken place a while ago.

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“Instead of doing a leg workout, I will build a cold food storage for your people. Approve me then as your warrior.”

“Oink?”

Chief Akush raised his thick eyebrows at the suggestion.

“Food storage, oink? What is that?”

“Exactly what the name suggests. It’s a storage that preserves food.”

“Does constructing that change anything, oink?”

“Yes, something will change.”

“What will?”

“Your meat won’t spoil easily.”

“Oink? Is that possible, oink?”

“Of course.”

Akush furrowed in disbelief and Lloyd smiled at the chief. *Okay, it's time to be confident.*

Thinking that in his head, Lloyd said, "Just imagine it, chief. You hunted a huge monster, but it starts to rot before you eat even half of it. It would be very sad to waste all that natural protein, don't you think?"

"Oiink!!! It's infuriating, oink!!"

"That's it," Lloyd agreed.

"Yes, oink!!"

"And now, imagine you can savor every shred of that meat because it's kept fresh in cold storage. All that juicy meat turns into rich nutrients in your body. Imagine them bulking your muscles. How's that? Pretty awesome, no?"

Whoosh! Chief Akush harshly exhaled through his nose instead of giving a response.

The thought thrilled the orc.

"Is that possible, oink?"

"Of course, it is. Who do you think I am?"

"Our savior, oink!"

"That's right," Lloyd agreed.

"Yes, oink!"

"Good. Thank you for trusting me. Now, before we start, let's sign a construction contract."

"A construction...contract, oink?"

“Yes, contracts are very important in these kinds of jobs. Javier?” Lloyd turned around.

Javier casually handed Lloyd a piece of paper and pen as if he was familiar with the current situation. Lloyd jotted down a simple, concise contract on the paper.

“This is the way it is. Any construction project that starts without any clear agreements is bound to be legally muddy, eventually leading to a conflict. And with our relationship, chief? It’d be very sad if such a thing were to happen, right?”

“Oink...I don’t know what you mean, but sure, oink.”

“Good thinking, chief. You are wise, indeed. Here. Take this.”

“Oink?”

“Sign your name at the bottom.”

“Sign, oink?”

“It’s the same as leaving a mark that you agree with the terms of the contract as a great chief.”

“Mark! I like it! I’m good at leaving that, oink!”

Akush then lifted his basketball-sized fist into the air and slammed it down on the paper. *Bam!* The contract was pressed four inches deep into the stone. *Dang. He’s a monster.* The chief orc was a monster but in a different way than Javier. It became clear to Lloyd how powerful the chief orc was. *Well, I’m not surprised, really. Even Javier struggled to suppress him in the novel.* Javier had just become a sword master at that part of the story.

This meant that this gigantic muscular orc held combat powers equal to a high-level sword expert and sword master. *This guy has nothing but his physical strength. He doesn’t know how to use mana at all, and yet that’s how formidable he is.* The more he thought about him, the more ghastly this

orc was. However, he didn’t need to be in fear right now because this muscle giant was on his side. Lloyd grinned.

“Thank you, chief, for arriving at a wise choice. You just have to trust me from now on.”

“Of course! Akush trusts human Lloyd, oink!”

“Yes, please leave the job to me.”

Lloyd signed his name on the paper glued to the floor. The contract went on like this:

[Lloyd Frontera will make a seokbinggo for the orc tribe.]

[The orc tribe will acknowledge Lloyd Frontera as a warrior and pay for the construction.]

[The payment for construction will be in the form of fitness tools for the orcs to use in the village.]

[However, Lloyd Frontera will refine the stones and make fitness tools that weigh the same as the payments.]

In short, the contract benefited both sides, and no one was at a loss. *No one’s losing in this contract. It’s a win-win for everyone.* The orcs used their gold and other treasures as fitness instruments. They didn’t see any other value to them and Lloyd would get compensated with those valueless treasures for the construction.

In return, they’d be blessed with a more efficient set of new tools made out of stones and a giant refrigerator that would preserve their food. Thus, the contract was beneficial to both sides.

“This is the reason why we can’t let them down. We need to construct a good one. Let’s see, so this can be the entrance.”

Lloyd spoke as he surveyed the land and imagined the series of events that led up to this point. He was bent on doing a great job with the seokbinggo.

This was only natural for him because he understood the importance of trust. Orcs may look dull and dumb, but you could never think lightly of them. Doing a haphazard job in construction for immediate profit would backfire eventually, and karma would hit him very hard. Karma would hit especially hard when his opponent was that muscular monster. *It's better for me in the long term to maintain the trust they have in me.* Orcs asserted massive influence and power over the land. Every orc was tough and powerful. If a war broke out, dozens of orc villages in the area would form an alliance in the blink of an eye that could stand against the elite forces of a nation.

So it's important that I gain the orc's trust all the more. There was even a possibility that Lloyd could earn more RP from them. Thinking that in his head, Lloyd did his best to survey and design the seokbinggo. *The entrance and exit will be southward. The main storage where the ice and food will be stored will face north as it's colder there.* Lloyd's plan was modeled after the seokbinggo. When he was a freshman, he was part of a student society that studied traditional architecture. That experience was helping him a lot now.

Anyway, it's really dry here. The village sat in the dry wilderness. This means that the seokbinggo here would be more efficient than the one in Joseon.

Aside from these, he meticulously inspected and designated multiple factors that would make the facility more functional. *It's important to direct the hot air above.* The facility was a semi-basement type as half of the storage sat below the ground level. The other half, which was a ceiling, was elevated above the ground. And it was shaped like an arch.

Lloyd then created a structure that would transfer the heat outside *I need to make some uneven spaces between the arched ceiling since that's where the heat will be trapped. The center of the dug area must be equipped with a ventilation facility, so the heat will then be transferred outside. Lastly, I just have to put some stone covers right above the ventilation to prevent the sun and rain from getting in...Done.*

Flash! A hologram of a floor plan appeared in front of his eyes. The hologram showed the ceiling structure of the facility and Lloyd remembered to make a slope on the floor.

The ice will melt and create a puddle without a slope on the ground, which will make the melting happen faster... So the entrance area was elevated more than the north side, where the storage sat. Then, he built a drain at the end of the storage and focused on keeping the facility cold.

The retaining walls were placed on the north and south of the entrance. This was to make the cold air flowing down from the mountain range in the winter hit the walls and enter the ice storage. Afterward, he secured the areas for insulation. Four days later, Lloyd was finally done with the design.

“Whew, the floor plan is done.”

He printed out the floor plan with the optional skill he acquired after his surveying skill leveled up. Once the floor plan was completed, Lloyd proceeded to the next part of the job—acquiring construction supplies. *I can procure mud and limestone for the waterproof layer in the ceiling. And rice husks, wheat straws, and sawdust can be acquired for insulation after I send some of my men back to the fiefdom. I can just use the sandbar in the area to carpet the final layer of the outside. The only problem is the granite.* Lloyd gazed westward.

The eastern mountain range sat between the Frontera barony and this wilderness. The foot of the hill was brightly glimmering against the morning sun because of the granite in the bedrock.

Granite is imperative to construction. Granite was created from felsic magma being cooled off, and the formation process allowed the rock to be strong and homogenous.

As such, this meant that it hardly got warped or broken into pieces due to its lack of layers inside. *That’s why granite is widely used in the modern world as a supporting stone for semiconductors or measuring devices that require precision.* Granite was solid, and it wasn’t prone to change, becoming a popular construction material that could last for several years.

This was especially the case for seokbinggo construction, as it required lasting insulation and waterproofing. However, that wasn't to say it didn't have any downsides. *First and foremost, it's extremely tricky to process it.* The harder the rock was, the harder it was to break.

Furthermore, the absence of layers inside made it impossible for him to break it into the shape he wanted. So it was infinitely challenging to refine or process the granite in the shape or size one wished. *That explains why the Buddha statues used to be so edgy and crude.* The Korean Peninsula was rich in granite. Thanks to that, Lloyd's ancestors carved the hard rock by hand one after another. They went through excruciatingly long hours in the process. However, Lloyd wasn't interested in doing manual labor just like his ancestors, especially when the job was for the orcs, not for his people.

He didn't wish to spend a lot of time building an ice storage on someone else's land.

After racking his brain to find a solution, he turned around when he found one at last.

He called the silver-haired knight silently standing behind him.

"Hey, Javier."

"Did you call me?"

"Yes, I did. Let me ask you something."

"Do speak, Young Master."

"Can you split a rock with your sword?"

"Yes."

"How big?"

"I've succeeded with rocks that are about three feet thick."

"For real?"

“Yes.” Javier nonchalantly nodded.

This surprised Lloyd. A sword, no matter how well-made, was nothing but a blade of steel that only weighed a few pounds. Yet here was Javier, telling Lloyd that he could slice a 2,200-pound rock in one sweeping cut. Lloyd hid his emotions and instead, he scoffed at Javier.

“Yeah? I thought you could do better.”

“I thought you’d be able to easily slice and stab through rocks dozens of feet thick. Tsk.”

“What you just described sounds hard even for a sword master...”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“Aren’t you just coming up with an excuse because you can’t do it?”

“No.”

“No?”

“Yes.”

“You sure?”

“Yes.”

Javier’s tone dripped with iciness, just slightly more than his daily tone. It was probably because Lloyd was annoyingly harping on the subject.

“I am oblivious to your intentions, but if you are trying to make an unreasonable request by abusing your status, I refuse in advance.”

“Oh, look at you. Are you on strike?”

“I am saying this in advance because I cannot do something that is beyond my powers. Both of us will be unhappy eventually if we ignore that.”

“Both of us will be unhappy?”

“Yes.”

“If I push you to do something that’s beyond your powers?”

“We surely will be. May I speak honestly?”

“Go ahead.”

“You are trying to acquire the stones to build a structure you call a seokbinggo.”

“You’re right,” Lloyd conceded.

“And you are trying to use me for the job by making me slice the rocks with my sword. I’m letting you know in advance because I knew what was coming.”

“So, are you saying that you refuse to be a stonemason because that’s not in your job description?”

“Yes, but mainly because the job is impossible with a sword.”

“Tsk, how insolent of you.”

“Thank you,” Javier said.

He then bowed. *You think you won this one?* The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose. Lloyd flashed a meaningful grin at Javier, who was basking in his victory.

“What if I can make you do it?”

“Pardon?” Javier asked.

“What if I make you slice and blast those heavy rocks with just your sword? Will you do what I ask?”

“I’m not following what you mean...”

Javier trailed off and Lloyd grinned. He knew there was a way. Javier, in the novel, had mastered a destructive skill midway through the story and now, Lloyd planned to make Javier learn it earlier. It was time for some advanced lessons.

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Chapter 33: Muscles and Express Construction (1)

“Create a hole that is dozens of feet deep with a sword? I do not know what you mean.”

Javier furrowed his brows. The way he looked at Lloyd was filled with incredulity and annoyance.

“Something does not add up here. May I speak honestly?”

“Speak honestly?”

“Yes.”

“No thanks. You’re going to drop truth bombs on me all over again.”

“Again, I have never dropped anything on you or hurt you, Master Lloyd.”

“Yes, you have.”

“When did I ever do that?”

“In the ant cave. You punched me in the gut.”

“Well, that’s...”

“Oh, I almost forgot. You slapped me three times in a row to wake me up as well. Am I wrong?”

“Twice, actually. I stopped before landing the third blow since you woke up.”

“Oh, so you’re saying that you wish you had slapped me, yeah?”

“Of course, I do...not.”

“Anyway, to go back and tell you frankly, I have never heard of anyone who succeeded in what you just described.”

“None?”

“None, not even of a sword master.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

Javier was right. A sword couldn’t create a hole several feet deep in the rock. Moreover, blast it from the inside? He had never even heard of such a feat. Such a feat was impossible for even any of the countless sword masters recorded in history.

Well, it was even impossible for Sir Mikael, the founding king, who fell behind others at first but rose to be the most powerful swordsman in history. The record shows that Sir Mikael’s sword aura extended as far as three feet. Add to the length of the blade, and he must have been able to slice or destroy anything a little over 6 feet ahead of him. The sword aura. This technique referred to adding a layer of highly concentrated mana to the sword. It was a signature skill for sword masters as they were the only ones who could use it. However, the skill had its limits despite its destructiveness. The sword master could not attack outside the range of their aura

After all, swords are short-range weapons. No matter how fatal an attack was, the sword master still needed to move close to slash and stab their opponent. They weren’t like mages who could barrage their opponents with magic from a distance. That was what differentiated them from mages. At the same time, it was also their weakness.

“Master Lloyd, you are ignoring common sense. You are stating that you will teach me an imaginary skill that doesn’t exist. It’s like...”

“I’m losing it?”

“Yes.”

Javier immediately nodded his head.

“You surely are. The words you speak can only come out of someone who is crazy, insane, or losing their mind.

“Hey, I know you may think you’re right about this one, but don’t be so judgy.”

“Judgy? What is that?”

“Haa, never mind. Anyway...”

Lloyd chuckled.

“What if I teach you that skill?”

“Are you really saying that you can do it?”

“Yeah! Just answer the question.”

“If your bluffing is proven to be true...”

Javier’s eyes grew serious.

“I shall happily follow your will.”

“Really? You would do anything I ask you?”

“Of course.” Javier nodded.

If what Lloyd was saying proved to be true, he had nothing to lose. But at the same time, he thought to himself that Lloyd was bluffing. It was just one of his pretentious talks. There was no way for such a gibberish, senseless thing to be true.

“Good. We have a deal. Well then...”

Lloyd held out his hand. Then, he grabbed Javier on the shoulder and nonchalantly said, “Draw your sword, up your mana circle rotation to the max, and force the two circles to collide by overlapping them together.”

“Excuse me...?”

“Oh, but the remaining circles must not be used for the collision. The others have to protect the heart. Or else, your heart rate will go up from the trauma until it completely stops. One boom, and you’ll be kicking the bucket.”

“Why would I kick the bucket...?”

“Just try it, will you?”

“Here? Now?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded his head and Javier was flustered. *Is it possible?* He felt like he was going against common sense. The Asrahan Core Technique almost felt like a part of his body, but this technique felt strange.

He had never tried anything like it. He never gave a thought that it would be possible. Javier’s doubts were only logical. Each mana circle rotated around the heart faster, with more power generated into it. Once the rotation gained speed, the repulsive power in each circle increased. Afterward, the circles pushed the other away like two opposing magnetic poles, and here was Lloyd, suggesting to collide them by force.

“It’s all right. Just make sure that you protect your heart with the other circle. Everything’s going to be fine that way.”

Lloyd sounded way too casual, and his tone made him less trustworthy for Javier. But there was something that was hidden from Javier’s knowledge, and it was that he came up with this very skill by himself in the novel. It made him the strongest knight that ever set foot on the Laurasia continent.

But, of course, that happens much later on in the story. Lloyd recalled the story in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Mana blast was the name of the technique. Javier was already a sword master by the time he developed this technique. He also had his fourth circle equipped.

The combination of the sword master status and quadra-circle alone was enough to make him the most powerful knight in history.

But one day, he was faced with an obstacle that even he could not surpass, Namaran's Wall.

The wall was under destructive, evil magic. Behind it, thousands of refugees direly waited for Javier to save them. This magic wall stood indomitable despite the powerful combination of the aura-layered sword and the amplification of the quadra-circle. Time passed without any success, and the day the evil mage would appear came near.

Every single refuge was doomed to be sacrificed. When the following morning rolled around, Javier attempted the final assault to bring down the wall. His frantic attempt led to a collision of two circles, causing an unimaginable force to explode and crumble the wall at once. This was the first time he ever used the mana blast. *After that event, it became his go-to skill, along with the Asrahan Core Technique.*

And now, Lloyd was trying to teach that very skill to Javier. It was a strange experience at the same time, being able to teach the soon-to-be sword master. *I should master this once I can manage the triple circle.* Even though Lloyd wanted to use the skill, he couldn't learn it at the moment. He could only create two circles, and the skill required an additional one to protect his heart.

In short, the mana blast required three circles to be used. *But even those who can use triple circles don't have it easy.* That was true for Javier as well. With that thought in mind, Lloyd put on a smirk.

"Hey, you're still hesitating. Am I that hard to trust?"

"Are you scared?" Lloyd asked.

"Of course not. However..."

"However?"

“I need you to promise me one thing.”

“Hmm...Promise you what?”

“That skill you just taught me...”

“Uh-huh.”

“If it is a lie or an attempt to pull my leg...”

“Yeah?”

“Promise me that you will infinitely extend your lullaby service for free.”

“What the?”

The suggestion was bolder than Lloyd thought. At the same time, it granted Lloyd a glimpse of what Javier thought of his lullabies.

“Hey,” Lloyd said, the corners of his eyes rising.

“I see your body’s become dependent on my lullaby service.”

Flinch. Javier’s shoulders startled very faintly and Lloyd continued to speak.

“Oh, there’s no point in hiding. It’s way too obvious.”

“You are overly speculating.”

“Come on. Look me in the eyes when you say it.”

“I have never avoided your gaze.”

“I guess my eyes sit below my nose.”

“You know what? Drop it. I give you my word.”

“Do you really mean it?”

“Yes. I promise you a lifetime extension of my service if it’s found that I was lying. Completely free, moreover.”

“You promised.”

“Yeah, yeah. Just go try now. Do you remember what I told you?”

“Yes.”

Swish! Javier pulled out his long sword. Lloyd took a few steps back. *I’m sort of worried because it’s his first try...But it’s Javier we’re talking about. He’s gonna be okay.* When it came to the Asrahan Core Technique, Javier was way ahead of Lloyd. He had a triple circle with him. He controlled each of the mana circles exceedingly well like a seasoned expert.

And so, while he knew that this was Javier’s first attempt at the skill, Lloyd believed that nothing bad would happen to his heart. *The next few days are going to be an uphill battle for him.* This technique involved clashing the two mana circles madly spinning near the heart.

That would put a great strain and pressure on his body, and it’d take time to get used to it, no matter how much of a genius he was. *At best, he’d need a week. Or two weeks, even. I gotta adjust the schedule because that’s the only time the quarrying work can be done-*

Thwack!

“It was a success.”

Something utterly unbelievable happened. Lloyd stared at Javier a few steps away from him, his mouth agape. Then, he looked further behind. There was a mark on the floor that wasn’t there a while ago.

“I worried for nothing. It turned out to be not difficult.”

A long furrow behind him stretched as far as 30 feet. Lloyd noticed how even and delicate the mark was. The long hole appeared from the inside, which meant that the explosion started from there to extend all the way straight.

“Hey, Javier?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“Are you a monster?”

“No. I am, of course, a human.”

No, I think you’re a monster. Or the rumored family friend my mother knows. Lloyd stared at Javier with an embarrassed look and a corner of his lip rose elegantly.

“Thank you, Master Lloyd. Now I know that you were not making fun of me.”

“You learned that just now?”

“Yes.”

“Whew. You are so brazen.”

“I had no choice. I have never thought of it that way.”

“How about now? Can you make sense of it?”

“Yes, however...”

“However? What is it again?”

“I am curious how you managed to come up with such a brilliant technique.”

“Why, am I not allowed to come up with one?”

“Of course, it’s not that, but...”

Javier stuttered and tightening the muscles around his neck, Lloyd said,

“Never mind. Keep your promise. Can we agree that I'm not teasing you?”

“Yes.”

“Does that mean you’ll do what I tell you to do without a fight?”

“I am at your service.”

He’s a bit snobby, but he does it when he says he will. Javier nodded. Just then, a message popped in front of his eyes.

Ding Dong.

[Javier Asrahan is very grateful for what you are doing for him.]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by three points.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: -11]

[You have earned 54 RP by improving relationships with main characters.]

[Current RP: 561]

Amazing. Lloyd was certain that Javier had raised his white flag for certain. Now, it was time to test him out for the quarry work.

***

“Okay, from now on, you’ll be a human dynamite.”

The following morning rolled around. Lloyd and Javier were on the far western side of the orc village. Lloyd held up a large brush as he stood on the granite bedrock that revealed the range foot. He dipped the brush into the jar he was carrying in his arms. *Splash.* The red ink had been given by the orcs. He held up the dipped brush and splotched the ground in even intervals.

“Here. And here. Here too.”

Sweep! Sweep! Sweep! Red dots as big as his fist were painted on the ground.

“Do you see these points?”

“Yes, is that where I need to stab my sword?”

“Yes. Smart boy. Stab, mana circle collision, bang. Got it?”

“I understand. By the way, how deep should I go?”

“Uhm, thirty feet.”

“Thirty feet?”

“That’s the deepest you can get at this moment, right?”

“Yes.”

“Stab it evenly. And make an explosion with all the power you got.”

Lloyd clenched his fists and opened them up.

“I marked those dots because I already calculated the depth. But make sure you run back here after making the explosion, okay? I don’t want you to be pressed under the rocks and go ouch. Okay?”

“Yes...” Javier nodded.

Lloyd moved far, far away from the explosion spot. He held up his arms high, facing Javier.

“Three! Two! One! Fire in the hole!” Lloyd shouted.

A second later, he saw Javier holding up his sword, and a few more seconds later, Javier disappeared from his sight. No, he grew faint. Javier was stabbing the rocks with his sword as he moved around at lightning speed. Lloyd clenched his fists as he saw Javier do so. *Please succeed.* His success would make the quarry job thousands of times easier.

Just like how Alfred Nobel revolutionized quarry work and shortened the year of painstaking work it used to require to a mere few days by inventing

dynamite. If Javier acted as the ANFO or New MITE, both of which were used to create a confined blast, Lloyd could complete the seokbinggo within this month. *I taught you the mana blast for this very reason! So show me that it wasn't all for nothing!* Lloyd wished in his heart and then, he saw it happen. *Flash!*

Rays of light burst out of the large granite bedrock. Lloyd noticed Javier rushing in his direction. Javier came to a stop a second later.

"I did it."

Clank! Javier put the sword back into the sheath. Just then... *Boom!* A massive shockwave and subsequent sandstorm engulfed the land. The large bedrock crumbled to dozens of pieces like a giant collapsing to the floor.

Rumble! The ground shook, followed by an overwhelming roar. Lloyd tightly squeezed his fist without realizing it. He was certain.

"You did it."

At last, all preparations for the construction were complete. It was now time to get started.

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Chapter 34: Muscles and Express Construction (2)

“Fire in the hole!”

Whoosh! Flash! It was a bright morning and Lloyd’s loud shout cut across the sky. At the same time, Javier’s long sword glimmered. A blinding flash of light cut deep into the granite.

A second later, it exploded. *Crack!*

The granite that has endured the test of time for thousands and thousands of years exploded and crumbled to pieces. A crack appeared in the bedrock in one unified direction. And the chasm deepened a second later, causing it to crumble to several pieces as the weight became unbearable. *Rumble!* Pieces of granite that resembled dice fell out, each almost weighing a ton.

“Good job, Javier!” Lloyd gave Javier a thumbs up.

Javier wiped his forehead with a handkerchief. He did his part and now, it was Ppodong’s time to shine.

“Hey, Ppodong.”

“Ppodong?”

“Do you want to eat this? It’s a red sunflower seed.”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“I had this specially ordered just for you. A set includes only one piece of each of the red and blue seeds, and I had to pay a whopping 1 RP for it.”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“Do you know how many sets I bought last night? 50. I spent a whopping 50 RP in total. You do know that I’m working my head off because I want to give you and Bangul the best of the best, right?”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“So, what do you say? Will you enjoy it?”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong happily took the red sunflower seed from Lloyd’s palm and he began to chew.

Lloyd stepped far back and watched the hamster grow in gigantic size. *Bam!* A 30-foot monster appeared.

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“Yes, good job, Ppodong. You deserve a good rub.”

“Ppodong!”

“Good boy. Hey, Ppodong, could you move that, please?”

Lloyd pointed at the cube-shaped granite hunks.

“Just to the orc village. How about it? Can you do it?”

“Ppodong!” The hamster nodded his large, round head.

Then, he waddled over to the granite chunks and stretched out his hands at them. He opened up his cute mouth and shoved the granite into his mouth.

“Ppudung? Ppu-pu-dung!”

One side of his cheek became square.

“Great job, Ppodong. Can you stash those as well?”

“Ppu-pu-dung!”

The other side of his cheek became square too. Lloyd hopped on Ppodong’s back.

“Let’s go!”

“Ppudung?”

Ppodong’s gait was light and quick even with a mouthful of weighty granite chunks. He headed to the orc village as fast as a dump truck. Once Ppodong transferred the rocks to the village, it was time for Lloyd, Arosh, and the 20 civil engineer soldiers to shine.

“The rocks are here, oink!”

“Everyone, get ready!”

Zoom! They were waiting at the construction site and as Lloyd appeared in the distance, they held up their chisels, hammers, and pickaxes. Ppodong stopped and spat out the chunks of granite. Everyone started to charge at them.

“Arosh will break it, oink!”

“Let’s show the orcs what we got!”

“Woah!!!”

That began the sweaty, painstaking construction for Arosh and the rest of the soldiers.

They cut the chunks according to the mark Lloyd drew for them and evened them out to be made into bricks. Amid the hustle and bustle, Ppodong busied himself with another job.

“Hey, Ppodong?”

“Ppodong?”

“Could you please dig here? From here to here. Around this much. 20-feet deep.”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

Lloyd began to draw lines with a tree branch on the ground. It seemed random, but he was actually following the floor plan of the seokbinggo. The optional design skill allowed him to manufacture a 2D floor plan. *This is so handy. I can't believe that the floor plan is appearing right on the ground in real-time.* He simply needed to summon the model of the seokbinggo he had designed beforehand and place it on the ground where the structure would be built.

A floor plan only he could see was engraved on the ground. So, the lines Lloyd drew exactly matched the ones in the floor plan. He clearly instructed Ppodong how deep and wide he must dig the hole.

"All right, I trust you with this."

"Ppodong!"

Ppodong raised his arms up high and the fierce digging began. *Swish! Swish! Swish!*

Now, even though the land was pretty much dry, it couldn't stop Ppodong from skillfully scooping the earth. He spooned out the earth with his paws at a fierce speed and a huge amount of the soil got excavated. Despite being assaulted by sand particles all over his face, Lloyd stayed beside his hamster friend. More sand flew toward his face and body, yet Lloyd never left Ppodong's side as he knew that the hamster was working hard for him.

From time to time, Lloyd carefully inspected Ppodong's work to check if there were any errors in the digging. He made sure that Ppodong scooped just the right amount of sand, nothing more and nothing less. Every inch of the ground was surveyed through his skills.

When he discovered an error, he hopped down with a shovel in his hand. He securely filled in the areas Ppodong left out and carefully scooped out the areas with excess sand.

Digging and mending the ground...Lloyd actualized the floor plan as meticulously as possible, leaving no room for error. *Digging the ground is the most important part of construction. That's true regardless of what I'm*

building. Since it involved constructing the foundation of the facility, he could never do the task perfunctorily. Otherwise, a problem could arise in the future in the facility.

And if that happens, my credibility will be affected, and people will talk badly of me. That would hurt my business, and I won't be able to maintain it for long.

Lloyd understood how crucial *credibility was i*n this industry. Be it a human or an orc, it didn't matter. The orc chief was a client who had signed a construction contract with Lloyd.

Humans, orcs, and monsters...It hardly mattered to Lloyd who the client was. Everyone was a client as long as the contract was signed.

Do I think this way because I'm a seasoned professional? Nah! It's because they pay me! Anybody who pays me for a job is my king, my idol! So he needed to ensure the best results for his clients. That required him to pour all his efforts into the business. Lloyd imagined how rich he would be in the future after this construction, and that motivated him to put his nose to the grindstone.

With that thought, Lloyd happily let the sweat drip down his forehead.

A few days passed in a flash but the work was still tough and exhausting. Javier blasted the granite and shattered it into chunks. Ppodong transferred the rocks to the site. Arosh and the soldiers smoothened them. Lloyd evened out the ground and checked over it. About ten days later, the foundation work was finished.

"We don't have any time to rest! Let's keep going!"

"Yes, Master!"

Lloyd took off his shirt and led the way. He joined the soldiers in transferring the granite bricks and stacked them up on the smoothened ground. The experience he gained in South Korea with laying out tiles helped him a lot.

Although, these bricks are incomparably large and heavy! Nevertheless, both shared the same principle: finishing the ground with heavy material. The process had many commonalities: First, you solidified the ground. Second, you pre-set the level and slope. Third, you covered the ground with rocks. Last, you filled the gaps between the rocks.

The only difference was in the last step, where he needed to waterproof the mixture by mixing the mud with limestone instead of tile grout filler. Anyway, the overall construction went smoothly until the floor was finished. As soon as Lloyd proceeded to stack up the bricks to make the walls, problems arose.

“Arghah!!!” One of the civil engineers moaned strangely. It was followed by a snapping sound, which came from his back.

“Hey, you okay?”

“Argh...It looks like my back is sprained.”

The man had to stay bedridden for several days in pain. The granite proved to be too heavy for him to lift. Starting with him, more soldiers got similarly injured. More and more spent their time in bed as days passed by and their injuries weren't exclusive to the back. Some got hurt in the wrist while others got hurt in the shoulders. Even the experienced soldiers, who had worked on several different past projects, ended up in the same state.

At last, Lloyd was the only one left who could lift up the bricks. Javier wasn’t there to help him as he was already in bed, recovering from terrible fatigue. His body had been worn down from using the mana blast for several days in a row.

Lloyd furrowed his brows.

This is a pickle. I wish Arosh was here. Goodness. Why did he have to go out hunting now?

To Lloyd’s misfortune, Arosh wasn’t in the village. At the time the floor was getting finished, he was fulfilling his duty as a warrior and on a group

hunt with his village orcs. *I can't give Ppodong the red seed, either.* Since the floor was just finished, the rocks hadn't been set in place yet. The whole floor could be ruined if Ppodong, who was several tons heavy, waddled around to stack the bricks.

What should I do? Lloyd contemplated a solution. The problem lay in the weight of the rocks. But he couldn't cut down the size, either. *Otherwise, it wouldn't be insulated.*

The sole purpose of building the seokbinggo was to keep the temperature cold. And so, large and thick rocks were imperative to prevent the heat from entering. *Should I just wait until the ground firms up? Is Ppodong the only option I have?* That looked like the best plan for the soldiers' safety. One afternoon, when Lloyd was still mulling over the matter, the solution was simply handed over to him in a rather unexpected way.

"Oink?! You cannot lift that like that, oink!"

A group of orcs was always at the construction site to watch the process. They oinked in excitement when Ppodong and Lloyd smoothened the ground and when soldiers chiseled the rocks. It was the same this day. Lloyd was struggling to stack the rocks all alone. Its weight left a great toll on him but the job wasn't entirely impossible as he had the Asrahan Core Technique. It was more like weight training for him. That's when the orcs began to interrupt and meddle.

"Human! You're lifting that wrong, oink!"

"Pardon?" Javier asked.

Lloyd lifted his head, all flushed and red because of the heavy weight of rock in his arms.

A senile orc, who was looking down at the construction burrow from the ground, was speaking in his direction.

"What did you just say?"

“It’s just as I said. You’re not working your muscles if you lift like that, oink.”

“Whaat?”

“Straighten your back and stick your butt out. Your chest should be straight, too. And make sure your ankles are positioned flexibly because that’s the only way you can train your muscles, oink!!”

“Uhm, but I’m not doing this for exercise.”

“It doesn’t matter, oink!!”

After that, the other spectating orcs started to chime in too.

“Grab the lower part, oink!”

“Mind your breathing! Oink!”

“Rise faster when you lift it up, oink!”

“One more, oink!!”

The construction site suddenly transformed into a gym for highly seasoned, ripped, and motivated trainers. The orcs were the trainers, while Lloyd was the scrawny guy taking baby steps on his journey to be buff. Eventually, the orcs came forward out of frustration and demonstrated the movement themselves.

“Oink! Oink! He’s insufferable, oink!”

“Why can’t he do it properly?! Oink!”

“Let us show him, oink!!”

“Watch and learn, oink!”

About ten ripped orcs jumped down into the construction site and before Lloyd could stop them, each carried a granite brick in their arms. Their

veins, as thick as an anaconda, popped out.

“Alrighty! Oink!”

“Yes, oink!!”

The rock was terribly heavy for Lloyd, even with the help of the Asrahan Core Technique.

It took about three or four soldiers to carry just one. However, with these orcs, it was a cakewalk. It was like a giant gorilla that appeared in the Olympic weightlifting games and made fun of all the athletes by lifting up the weights without breaking a sweat.

“Wow.” Lloyd gaped at the incredible sight.

But he quickly jostled himself out of the daze and realized what he had to do.

He immediately exclaimed, “Oh, my, you’re so amazing!”

“Oink! This is nothing, Oink!”

“No. You are amazing. I never dreamed of being able to move that all the way over there, let alone lift it.”

“Over there, oink?”

Lloyd pointed at the half-finished wall. The orc glanced at it and scoffed.

“This is the problem with humans. Watch me, oink.”

As though he was lifting up an empty box, he raised the rock over his head. Afterward, he gently placed it on the area Lloyd just pointed to. *Clunk!* The rock thudded as the orc put it on top of the other rocks. He was able to put it down exactly where it needed to be.

Perfect. This is it. Lloyd discretely clenched his fists. Then, he moved on to carry another brick beside him. He struggled with it on purpose.

“Ow! Arghh!! I can’t do it. Why?”

“Tsk, tsk. Move, human. I will show you how it’s done, oink!!”

Thud! The orc placed the rock in its correct place once again. This process was repeated several times. Lloyd feigned weakness as he wiped the sweat off his face. He tugged at the heartstrings of the orcs by showing his incompetence, and it was enough to win him an Oscar.

Each time he did so, the orcs helped him out, feeling extremely sorry for this poor human. Their muscles trembled in regret and they never stopped trying to teach Lloyd the right posture. Lloyd noticed how warm and kind they were despite their menacing appearances with their bulky physique. Thanks to the orcs’ generous meddling, the wall was completed in just a few hours. However, he didn’t stop there.

“My, my! It’s harder to lift his way! Ouch! Yikes!”

Lloyd pretended to struggle the next day as well. He acted like someone trying to summon a gym trainer by misusing fitness equipment. The orcs must have talked about Lloyd the previous day as more orcs showed up this time. With a burning passion for imparting the proper way of working out, they started to instruct this miserable newbie, and thanks to their almost voluntary help, the outline of the arch-shaped ceiling was built in less than two days.

And they’re stacking up the bricks so well. The orcs were like a crane. They were so strong that they could quickly put the bricks in their proper spots. *Long live muscles.* Lloyd’s dream was getting materialized. The construction took place at lightning speed.

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Chapter 35: Muscles and Express Construction (3)

“Oink? What is this? Could it be that...the seokbinggo is completed already, oink?!”

Orc Arosh was a natural-born warrior. He battled against enemies and he hunted for the tribe. So, he naturally came to consider courage as a virtue. He had lived his whole life fighting. He was ignorant when it came to construction, so the processes and results all were a blur for him.

However, he understood this one thing and that was that no construction ended in a day. So, Arosh was shocked when he returned to the construction site.

“A few days ago, this area was just a hole! What happened?! It is full of rocks, oink!”

Arosh had every bit of reason to be taken aback. After all, he had to put down his shovel and leave to go hunting.

“*I’m sorry! I’ll hunt for a few days and come back, oink!”*

Hunting was one of the warriors’ sacred duties. Like all South Korean males who had to serve in the military and attend reserved force training, all the orcs were mandated to regularly attend group hunts and Arosh’s turn had come.

“*I will help you once I come back, oink!”* He spoke as he tapped Lloyd on the shoulder.

When the hunt was over, he ran as fast as he could to return to the construction site.

He did so to help out his savior Lloyd, but when he came back, his expectations were shattered. It had been only a few days, but everything changed. The empty lot, which everyone once struggled to burrow, was

replaced with a stone chamber made of thick, dense granite! Lloyd was standing in front of the stone chamber, no, the seokbinggo.

“Hey, Arosh. I know, right? I didn’t even realize how far I got. But it’s not fully constructed yet.”

Lloyd shrugged, unimpressed by the progress. Arosh gulped in nervousness.

He suddenly felt as if he was in the presence of a mythical creature. *Who in the world is my savior, oink?!* There was something great about him. He felt that way the more he spent time with Lloyd. Lloyd seemed to possess some kind of magical ability to create whatever he wanted. It wasn’t a rare event and it happened all the time.

Lloyd, my savior, gave an order to Javier. Then, a part of the rocky mountain got sliced into half. He brought those rocks and dug the ground, oink. And… There it was...a stone chamber Lloyd called the seokbinggo. *But he didn’t even use any magic, oink.* Arosh thought that Lloyd surpassed the limits of magic and so, he gave a thumbs up to Lloyd.

“My savior! You! I declare that you have a wide nostril! Oink!”

“A wide...nostril?”

“Yes, oink!!”

Lloyd cocked his head to the side. Arosh heavily exhaled through his nose.

“Wide nostrils make breathing easier. Easy breathing makes you last longer in fights and hunting. A tireless orc is the best warrior, oink!”

“Aha! Did you mean that as a compliment?”

“Of course, oink!”

Arosh smiled, his sharp fangs sticking out of his mouth. Lloyd chuckled.

“You’re very generous to compliment me over just this. I’m embarrassed. I actually never took a lesson on how to build a seokbinggo.”

“You didn’t learn how to make it, oink?”

“No, I didn’t. My major is civil engineering, so this area is a completely different field of study.”

“Civil...Oink?”

“Haha, there is such a thing like that. But I have always been interested in stuff like this. I guess it’s finally paying off.”

Lloyd had been a long-time enthusiast for traditional architecture, including the heated flooring system and seokbinggo. The student society he had signed up for back in college was also related to the field. What’s more, when his financial situation was good back then, he and his friends traveled to various places in the country to enjoy these architectural spectacles.

“But it’s all in the past now. Anyway, this seokbinggo is not finished yet. Sure, the shell is there, but I have yet to construct the inside. It’s far from being finished.”

Clap clap! Lloyd slapped the walls with his palm as he continued.

“But as you can see, the slope is there, and so are the waterway, arch, and ventilation system. All thanks to your strong warriors.”

It was true as the orc warriors were exceedingly strong. Each orc did more than what a hundred soldiers could do. They were like gorillas, and thanks to their bulky muscles, Lloyd enjoyed the comfort of working on the construction site without soiling his hands with dirt for the past few days.

The walls and arch ceiling were completed in the blink of an eye as the orcs transferred the bricks around using their muscles, but the construction wasn’t finished yet.

“It’s just flashy on the outside. But it can’t properly store anything right now.”

“Useless, oink?” asked Arosh.

“Uh-huh. There’s no insulation.”

Lloyd continued to speak.

“Even with the thickest granite bricks, it doesn’t have any insulation right now. Without additional layers of insulation, the heat during the summer will seep into the storage. So I need some other things to prevent that from happening.”

“Where can Arosh get the insulation, oink?”

“You don’t have to get anything,” said Lloyd.

“Nothing, oink?”

“Yep. We just have to wait. I sent ten soldiers back to my fiefdom to bring here the materials that can be used for insulation.”

It was true. Sometime before Lloyd taught Javier the mana blast, he selected ten of the strongest soldiers and sent them back to the fiefdom. Their mission was to come back with materials that could be used for insulation.

“I told them to bring the things that can’t be acquired here. Rice husks, wheat straws, and sawdust.”

The village lacked those materials because it sat in the middle of the wilderness. The barren land gave no crops, so the orcs knew nothing about farming. The materials Lloyd just mentioned could only be obtained on farms and agricultural lands.

“Hmm, they should be back soon. It’s been days since they left already,” Lloyd told Arosh.

Since they were expected soon, Lloyd simply waited for their return.

The waiting, however, dragged on. A day passed, two days passed, and just like that, even after four and five days later… No soldiers returned to the village even after ten days passed. Not a single sign indicated their return.

Hmm...This is strange. Lloyd waited for them as he fooled around with Javier in the village.

His gaze always darted to the west to seek any signs of their return, but as the waiting dragged on without any promise, Lloyd began to grow anxious.

They should have come back yesterday at the latest.

Since the soldiers took the same route Lloyd had traveled to get to the orc village from home, he was able to calculate how much time it would take for the soldiers to travel back to the fiefdom and return with the materials. According to his calculation, they should have been back the previous night at the latest.

“Hey, Javier.” Lloyd, who was lazily swinging his leg on the bed in the tent, spoke.

The answer was quick to return.

“Did you call me?” Javier asked.

“Yes, I did. I have an errand for you.”

“What is it...?”

“I need you to go to the mountain range over there.”

“Is it a search?”

“Yes.”

The two didn’t need to explain. Javier was already aware of what was going on with his young master lately and what concerned him.

“It would be a welcome and search party at the same time.”

“I suppose it will. Their belated arrival can only mean that something happened to them.” Lloyd spoke, his voice sounding firm.

The previous day was the final deadline for Lloyd. The delegation should have arrived yesterday. Lloyd had considered all the factors, their stamina, the weight and size of their loads, and even the delays the rough geography would pose. So, it was sufficient to say that the deadline factored in every possible element that could affect their arrival.

“But no news? This means that one of the two things happened. Something’s up, or they’re just goofing around.”

“I understand. I will go out on a search, taking the same route we took last time.”

“Yes and be careful out there. And while you’re at it, bring me a slushy.”

“Excuse me...?”

“Nothing. Off you go,” Lloyd said as he stuck his tongue out. Javier sighed instead of replying back.

He immediately rose up and stashed his camping bag along with several other items.

Once everything was set, he walked over to the exit. But before exiting, he halted and whipped around with a cynical expression unique to him.

Then, he deadpanned, “Right back at you...”

“Eh?!”

Javier then bolted out of the tent, leaving no second for Lloyd to respond.

“Huh! Hahaha.” Lloyd snorted involuntarily.

But he immediately grew serious a second later. *Whew...I hope everyone’s fine.* He had a bad feeling about this. Four days later, Lloyd’s bad feelings became a reality.

“I found this, Young Master.”

Javier spoke as he passed a tattered glove to Lloyd. Lloyd recognized the glove right away.

This is the glove we use. Lloyd recognized it because he had personally given those pairs to the soldiers who were doing construction work. Lloyd's face darkened.

He asked, "Where did you find it?"

"I found it in the valley located beside the eastern range. It is marked as 'Plogia Gorge' on the royal map. I found it two days ago."

"Explain more."

"My search initially focused on the route we had used to cross the range. I figured that would give me the best chance to bump into them as they may be coming late. But I didn't meet them even when I went over to Pano Peak and Pesano Peak. Of course, not a single footstep could be found, either. That told me one thing."

"Chances of them slacking around were zero."

"Yes, and after making that conclusion, I weighed the possibility that they might have fallen in an accident. And that's when I picked up this glove in Plogia Gorge and some strands of husks scattered around on the ground."

"So?" Lloyd asked.

"They were scattered by strands here and there. So I followed until I was led to a cave of considerable size."

"Plogia Gorge and a cave...So? Did you go in?"

"Yes, and there I found..."

Javier impassively rolled up his left sleeve, revealing his white arm and there was a serious wound on it, which stood in stark contrast with his nonchalant expression.

“This happened. There was a magic circle at the entrance. It got activated when I took a few steps inside.”

“Hey, are you all right...?”

“Yes, I am fine. It’s just a scrape.”

“A scrape? It looks like a bad burn.”

The wound was considerably big and it wasn’t a simple burn. Javier’s skin looked red and blue as though he suffered from a burn and frostbite at the same time.

“Although I cannot ascertain it, it looks like a form of curse magic. Thankfully, however, I managed to avoid the full blow.”

“I am truly fine. The wound didn’t spread into my muscles. I will be completely healed without any scars as long as I keep using my mana to heal the injury.”

“Okay, that is a relief, and as for the soldiers...”

“Yes, I am worried about the soldiers.”

Javier, who was impassive when he showed his wound, grew serious when he mentioned the soldiers.

“The husks went deeper into the cave. That means that they were...”

“Dragged in there,” Lloyd cut in and finished Javier’s words.

“It appears so.”

Javier lowered his head.

“Even after the blow from the first magic circle, I tried to get in several more times. But that was impossible. Please forgive me, Young Master.”

“Tsk. Don’t be.”

Javier didn’t do anything wrong. He actually did a fantastic job by making it out alive despite the defensive magic in the cave.

“I am a knight. My duty is not only to command the soldiers in the fiefdom but to keep the forces safe and intact. Thus, I failed in my duty to rescue them because I was not good enough. So if you give me another chance...”

Javier paused for a second before continuing.

“I shall return to the fiefdom as fast as possible and prepare to lay an offense on the cave.”

“Are you saying you’ll attack the cave?”

“Yes. Given the force of the protective magic at the entrance and the intricacy of the curse, I presume that a dark sorcerer of considerable power lurks in the cave. The sorcerer must have kidnapped our soldiers with evil intentions”

“It looks like time is of the essence then.”

“Precisely. The longer they are with the sorcerer, the greater danger they’ll be.”

“Hmm. Then let’s go right away,” suggested Lloyd.

His suggestion was out of the blue, as though he was just making a trip to a convenience store to buy some sushi or to an internet cafe for a game. His voice sounded very casual and confident. Javier’s eyes widened at his sudden suggestion.

“Pardon? What are you...”

“What are you, what? You said it yourself. The dark sorcerer took my men. And not to mention, he usurped all of my precious construction supplies. Isn’t that right?”

“Yes, but...”

Javier shook his head.

“But it is dangerous for you to personally go in this one without any prior preparation. It is too risky.”

“You think so?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes. Very much.”

Javier’s gaze was serious and resolute.

“Even I struggled against the defensive magic in there. Your miserable ability in fighting will stand no chance against our opponent, who is no other than a dark sorcerer. No one knows what evil traps are set up there.”

“Dang. Miserable? You’re not holding back at all.”

“It is just the truth when you are compared to me.”

“Well, whatever. So you are saying that I’ll be beaten up if I go now, right?”

“Precisely. I fear that you will be slashed, frozen, crushed, or fried to pieces with your current abilities. All black and crisp like a burnt prawn the cook forgot to pull out of a fryer on Thanksgiving.

“Hey...That description sounded very personal, you know that?”

“Not at all. You misunderstand me, Young Master.”

“Misunderstanding, my ass. It sounded super serious.”

Lloyd chuckled and stood up. Before he knew it, there was a fully packed bag in his hand.

The bag contained food and other supplies that would last several days in the mountain.

“Let’s go then.”

“Excuse me?”

“I told you. We should go to that cave right now. You said we were short on time. The longer we leave them hostage, the more danger they’ll be in.”

“Yes, it is true, but right now...”

“It’s alright. Just trust me on this.” Lloyd spoke as he carried another bag and tossed it into Javier’s arms.

“Come along quickly. If not, I’m going to leave you behind.”

Javier took the bag in a daze. But the knight’s face had darkened. This act was far too reckless. However, there was something Javier was oblivious to but was known to Lloyd.

The cave in Plogia Gorge, no, the dungeon of the dark sorcerer, which he had to leave, appeared in *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

In the novel, Javier laid his attack on the cave a few years after the current time. Lloyd had read about it and so, he knew how they should storm the dungeon. However, Javier was completely unaware of this. *The guy who got beaten up by Javier in the gorge episode...What was his name? Was it Lupellan?*

Crack! Lloyd gritted his teeth. He didn’t care whether or not there was a defensive curse magic circle in there. It was time for Lloyd to teach the sorcerer what fate awaited those who messed with his men and construction supplies. As payback, Lloyd resolved to loot anything that had value in the dungeon. Even the smallest things would become his. Death would be a sweet escape for the sorcerer. But he wouldn’t get it easily. Lloyd was determined to squeeze him dry.

So, in short, you’re dead meat.

With the goals of retaliation and extortion in mind, Lloyd headed to the gorge.

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Chapter 36: True Repentance (1)

“Master Lloyd, do you plan on going inside the cave?”

“Of course,” Lloyd answered as he looked up at the sky.

There wasn’t a cloud in the sky. Therefore, the sun should have been scorching everything under it. However, the place was completely absent of sunlight and they were instead besieged by dreary shadows. *What a foreboding place this is.* Lloyd unwittingly shrugged.

The Plogia Gorge turned out to be narrower and deeper than what he had pictured in mind.

So it was extremely difficult for the sun to reach the bottom of the gorge. *It looks like this place was out of the sun for tens of thousands of years.* Damp moss and unknown mushrooms carpeted the rocks, and not a single blade of grass grew in between the cracks.

It was especially so at the dungeon entrance Lloyd was looking at.

“But it is still dangerous. Like I have told you countless times over the past few days.”

Javier’s distinct cold and dry voice pierced into Lloyd’s ears.

“Master Lloyd, it is not too late to go back. Again, we are dealing with a sorcerer.”

“It would be better to gear up in the fiefdom first and come back here afterward.”

“Master Lloyd?” Javier called again.

“Yes.”

“Are you listening to me?” Javier inquired.

“No. You’re talking to a wall.”

Lloyd, still looking at the entrance, spoke. “By chance, are you a parrot? You’ve been hitting me over the head with the same warning ever since we left the village.”

“When did I...”

“What do you mean, when? You’ve been harping on me nonstop. Master Lloyd, it’s dangerous. Master Lloyd, it’s reckless. Master Lloyd, it cannot be done. Master Lloyd, you hide. I will count. No, not the last one. Anyway...”

Lloyd wrinkled his nose.

“Your opinion. I don’t like it.”

“How so?”

Javier shot back with a question right away.

Lloyd immediately answered him.

“Because you’re trying hard to hide the uncomfortable truth.”

“Excuse me?”

“You won’t be able to deny what I’m about to say.”

Lloyd turned around and faced Javier. Javier’s eyes trembled for a second as Lloyd’s gaze bore into him.

“Javier. No, Sir Asrahan. Let me ask you a question. Let’s say I do what you say, and we return here after properly gearing up at the fiefdom.”

“Yes.”

“What do you think will happen to the soldiers in there? They’ll all die, right?”

“That’s...”

“Right?”

“Yes...It is likely that they will.” Javier nodded reluctantly.

The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose. But it looked bitter.

“Yes, that will happen. That’s the uncomfortable truth you and I both know. But you made a judgment in your head. The successor of the fiefdom must not be put in danger to save some soldiers. Am I right?”

“Master Lloyd, I...”

“You don’t have to explain yourself. I accept that your judgment is reasonable. But it’s a different story when we know how to bypass the magic circles in the dungeon.”

“Excuse me?”

What now? Javier’s eyes narrowed.

“Do you already have a plan for getting through them?”

“Yeah. I think we can use the Asrahan Core Technique,” announced Lloyd.

“That technique, Young Master?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded.

Lloyd recalled *The Knight of Blood and Iron* in his head. *Javier, you used the technique in the dungeon a few years after you became the sword master.* The Javier in the story was much more seasoned than the current knight. With all the experience he had accumulated, he efficiently passed through the defensive magic circles and conquered the dungeon.

He did so by using the mana absorption skill in the Asrahan Core Technique. Thinking of the very method future Javier employed in the story,

Lloyd said, “Hey, have you ever chomped the mana in the air using the Asrahan Core Technique?”

“Chomped the mana?”

“Absorbed them.”

“Yes, of course,” Javier answered. “I do it regularly every day.”

“You bet you are. It’s the same for me, too. It’s a great training exercise because it can be done anywhere at any time,” Lloyd replied.

It was true, and for that reason, Lloyd used the Asrahan Core Technique every time he had the chance. He absorbed the natural mana spread in the air and amplified it just by a hair’s breadth, so no one would notice. This method proved to be an excellent training exercise.

“How do you feel when you absorb the mana in the air?”

“Well...”

Javier thought for a second and answered,

“I feel at peace.”

“Peace? How so?”

“I presume it is because there is always an equal amount of mana in the air.”

“I know, right?”

“Yes.”

That was true as well as the mana dispersed in the air was always uniform. It was rare for the mana to be clotted together or non-existent in one area so Lloyd and Javier absorbed an equal amount of mana into their circles.

“Exactly. It’s always uniform, just like when we breathe in air. But think about it. How would it feel if you used the same technique and absorbed the mana around the hidden magic circles?”

“Eh? Of course, that would...Oh.” Javier’s expression changed.

He gazed at Lloyd in realization.

“The mana that’s abnormally clumped together around the magic circles would flood into my own.”

“That’s right. I suppose this clarifies my message, right?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd brightly smiled. Javier was impressed, but he didn’t show it. The method was quite simple but the first of its kind. *Master Lloyd is right. Magic circles are devices that artificially absorb the mana in nature and arrange the energy to cause a magical reaction. So it’s obvious that there would be an abnormal cluster of mana around where there is a magic circle.* Therefore, finding the magic circle was simple: Use the Asrahan Core Technique and absorb the mana nearby. Keep absorbing and amble around. Then, watch out for the areas where a large amount of mana is absorbed. That’s where the traps are set.

Afterward, I can estimate the direction and distance of the mana clump. This means that I’ll be able to locate it just by my senses alone without having to see anything directly.

Javier’s gaze moved to Lloyd.

“Master Lloyd.”

“Hmm?”

“This sounds plausible.”

“I know, right?”

“Yes.” Javier nodded.

Lloyd brightly smiled. “So, what now? Feel like charging into the dungeon now?”

“Yes. So please wait out here. I will make the trip alone.”

“That’s not happening.”

“Why not? It’s dangerous inside as well.”

“Yeah, I know,” Lloyd spoke and glanced to the side.

“Hey, tell me, will you really feel relieved if you leave me behind here and go in alone?”

“Excuse me?”

“What guarantee do you have that it’s safe out here?”

“That’s...”

“You don’t, right?”

Javier didn’t answer. Come to think of it, Lloyd wasn’t wrong. Javier couldn’t ascertain that the dark sorcerer was the only dangerous entity in this gorge. If he left Lloyd alone out here and something happened... He wouldn’t be able to protect him. Javier sighed shortly. “I understand. Let us go in together. But on one condition.”

“Condition? Tell me.”

“Promise me that you will run away as soon as the situation turns dangerous.”

“When the situation turns dangerous?”

“Yes. I understand your desire to save the soldiers trapped inside, but your safety is the most important priority. So...”

Javier’s eyes and expression looked determined.

“Run away if the situation gets dangerous. Even if it means that you have to abandon me.”

“Huh? What gave you the idea that I won’t? Doesn’t it go without saying?”

Javier gaped at Lloyd.

“Of course, I will leave you behind and run away in a life-threatening situation. Please, that’s so obvious.”

“Hey, did I upset you? Are you pouting right now?”

“No.”

“No, my foot. Do you know what you look like right now?”

“I do not know. I do not wish to know.”

“Hey, hey, look at that. You’re upset.”

There was a slight wiggle in one of Javier’s eyebrows. Amused, Lloyd picked up his shovel.

The two then neared the dungeon entrance, and they naturally tensed and sharpened their senses as they entered.

Javier took a step forward and said, “I will take the front from here.”

“Yes, go, robot vacuum.”

“What is...a robot vacuum?”

“There’s something like that. It’s used to describe someone pretty.”

“But I am not pretty.”

“You know yourself very well. Focus now, Javier. This isn’t the time to fool around.”

“You started to fool around first...Whew, never mind.”

Javier’s expression became cool. It looked like he was getting focused. His gait became slow and measured. He slowly moved forward, one step at a time. The sight resembled a robot vacuum cleaning up the floor. Javier began to sense his surroundings as he minutely absorbed the mana around him.

Swoosh, swoosh. The dungeon entrance, located at the far bottom of the gorge, was completely windless. The only sound that rang in this area was Javier’s faint footsteps.

Sometime later...Javier stopped in his tracks.

“Here. Three steps ahead of me.”

“Hey, be more specific. That’s too vague. You’ve seen a pocket watch, haven’t you?”

“Yes.”

“Use the time in the watch to point to directions. Twelve o’clock for the front. Six for the rear. Just like that.”

This was how they needed to communicate. Using vague descriptions to point to directions could bring about disastrous consequences. For example, they could step on a magic circle if they pointed in the wrong direction by only a couple of centimeters. Javier must have realized what Lloyd meant. He corrected himself right away.

“Three steps, one o’clock,” Javier said.

“Okay.”

Swoosh, swoosh. Both of them moved. Javier continued feeling the mana in the air.

“Two o’clock. Two steps.”

“What about eleven?”

“Nothing is there.”

“Then let’s take two steps in the eleven o’clock direction.”

“Yes.”

“Found anything?”

“This is the nine o’clock direction. It’s clear ahead.”

“Okay. Let’s get moving again.”

Even after that, they continued to move and explore. There were, of course, some moments of danger. It turned out that the magic circles weren’t the only traps inside.

Clack! Swish! There was a faint noise under their feet. At the same time, arrows shot out from both of their sides. The arrows were smudged in green. They were poisonous.

“Ha!”

Clang! Lloyd raised his shovel to block the arrow flying right into Javier’s chest.

“Whew, thank you.”

“Don’t be. Let’s go. Keep moving. You watch out for the magic circles, and I’ll block the physical traps. Okay?”

“I understand. However...”

“However?”

“Don’t push yourself too much.”

“Aha. Do you mean that I shouldn’t put myself in harm’s way trying to protect you from things like arrows?”

“Exactly. If you find yourself in imminent danger, you may use me as your shield.”

“Actually, that was my plan from the beginning,” Lloyd said.

“You keep saying the obvious. Come on, man.”

Lloyd didn’t respond.

“Don’t tell me you’re upset again. Let’s move.”

They kept moving and Javier kept a watch on the magic circles while Lloyd protected both of them from any physical traps. *Can’t believe Javier did this all by himself in the novel.*

Of course, he managed to do so because he was a sword master. Now, he was just a high-level sword expert.

Thus, it was impossible for him to do both jobs at the same time. This mana-absorbing task was a wretchedly delicate job. *I said a large amount would be absorbed, but actually, it’s like picking out a tiny piece of spring onion after drinking a liter of ramen soup. No, it’s gotta be more delicate than that.* In short, the job required meticulous attentiveness. Lloyd had to help Javier laser-focus on his job.

“Okay, okay, let's go. Slowly. Don’t rush.”

Both of them walked forward slowly. It was getting dark already. The light from the outside streamed into the cave no more. The only source of light they could rely on was the torch but they continued to move. The two continued to watch for magic circles and avoid traps for thirty minutes, an hour, and before they knew it, two hours later.

Meanwhile, Lloyd kept going back to the story in the novel over and over again in his head. At the end of the long trap zone that’s where the trap that no one could ever avoid emerged.

It's about here based on the descriptions in the novel. Just then, the path in front of them swerved to the far right and became wide. The widened path ended with a vast, expansive space ahead of them. They finally arrived at the deepest part of the dungeon, the laboratory of the dark sorcerer.

Found it. They saw that the sorcerer was dressed in a black robe and sitting at the center table. The villain jolted out of his seat when he spotted them. He made a hand gesture at Lloyd and Javier. Just then, an inescapable trap was activated and it fell from the ceiling.

Creak. Clack. Crash! A thick metal wall dropped from the ceiling, completely blocking off the path ahead of them. The same thing happened behind them and another metal wall dropped. *Crash!* Thus, they found themselves trapped in between the gigantic metal walls.

There was more as a spraying noise came from the ceiling, emitting a sweet, aromatic gas into the closed space.

It was a powerful aromatic gas that induced sleep. However, Lloyd and Javier remained utterly calm. Not a single brow was raised. They were so calm that not even a cell in their organs flinched at their predicament.

"Hey, this situation feels quite familiar, don't you agree?"

"Well, it does now that you mention it."

The dark path, closed space, and isolation reminded Lloyd of the ant cave. The two of them chuckled under their breath at this familiar predicament. The two of them responded to the situation so casually that sometime later...The dark sorcerer realized that he had gotten ahead of himself.

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Chapter 37: True Repentance (2)

Fwoosh! Transparent gas flooded out of the ceiling. The sweet, aromatic gas tickled Lloyd's nose. It drifted deep into his brain, making him drowsy. The gas was notorious in the continent for its potency. It was so strong that even an elephant fell asleep after a whiff.

Once someone fell asleep from the gas, they would never be able to wake up again and die.

The gas was made out of asonia extracts.

Fwoosh! The closed space was soon filled to the brim with asonia gas. If it wasn't Lloyd and Javier but other ordinary people trapped in here, they would have collapsed already and entered into a permanent state of unconsciousness.

However, it was a different case for these two. *It's exactly the same as the novel!*

Lloyd casually looked around. The asonia gas kept assaulting and entering through his nose and mouth but not a single sign of drowsiness or sleepiness could be traced in Lloyd.

"Are you okay, Young Master?"

"Yeah." Lloyd's lips moved as he replied.

There was a white leaf in between his lips, and it had been staying there for quite a while.

The white leaf was the insonia that could neutralize the asonia's effects. *I've come prepared.*

The metal walls and fatal sleeping gas. These two things appeared in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Thus, he was able to prepare it prior to entering the dungeon.

He had plucked the insonia flower’s petals every time he saw one on the way here from the village. Afterward, he carefully stashed them in the pocket until he brought them out a while ago and bit them.

So the asonia gas failed to induce sleepiness in Lloyd and Javier. However, biting the leaf came at a cost. *This leaf...it’s very spicy. I wonder if this leaf wakes the bitter with its spiciness.* Lloyd assumed so as insonia was indeed spicy. Any part of his lips that touched the insonia leaf burned. It burned so much that he wondered if his lips were being burned to a crisp. *I’m so glad that I’m a Korean.* Thankfully, he was Korean and they loved spicy food so much that they dipped chili peppers into a spicy paste.

Lloyd was the same. He craved spicy food when it rained and often ordered hot wings.

On hot and sunny days, he made fermented bean soup with an excessive amount of spicy peppers that made him sweat. His tastes didn’t change even when he was forced to live in a dorm room after his family’s downfall. He used to pick out the spiciest triangle kimbap when he needed a quick bite in the convenience store. So, his lifelong diet built him a tolerance to capsaicin, and it was helping him very much at the moment. That was how he endured the burning pain and managed to keep biting on the leaf.

“How about you? You okay?” Lloyd asked as he endured the burning sensation.

Javier yawned a little to Lloyd’s surprise.

“Yes. But I am a little sleepy.”

“Sleepy? How bad?”

“Just enough to remind me what it feels like to be sleepy after meals.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

Javier was telling the truth. He was a bit sleepy but it wasn't enough to put him to sleep because, after all, he suffered from insomnia. Just like every insomniac, he had attempted every possible method to sleep like a log. He counted the sheep in his head. He put on the sleep shade. He took a bath, even a foot bath. He burned an incense candle good for sleep.

He meditated to find mental peace. He even attempted yoga, which he had heard was a trend in a far continent. When all else failed, he resorted to the last method—sniffing the asonia. However, it failed to cure his insomnia. So Javier's eyes were left bloodshot as he spent many waking nights without a wink of sleep. So, this small attack meant nothing to Javier.

However, it did cause an onrush of sadness in his heart. *Whew...Even the large amount of asonia gas doesn't affect me. It's really nothing compared to Master Lloyd's lullaby. Has it reached a point where I can't sleep without his singing?* Javier started to feel anxious as he realized that he might be stuck with this man for life. He became absolutely ashamed of himself at the thought. It was so bitter, like a cup of espresso. Javier unwittingly heaved a sigh. He strove to deny the reality and drew his sword. Now that he had learned that everyone was safe and unharmed, it was time for him to get out of this trap.

"Do you want me to smash the metal wall?"

"No."

Lloyd shook his head.

"I know you're not going to slash or stab it. You're gonna use the mana blast to penetrate the wall, right? Just so you know, my eardrums will pop the moment you use it in a closed area like this."

Javier guiltily laid down his sword. Lloyd instead picked up his shovel.

"Let's just dig. I'm going to make a tunnel. You follow."

"Yes."

With that, Lloyd began shoveling. He activated the optional skills to the Asrahan Core Technique. *Energizer.*

Ding Dong.

[The skill option of the Asrahan Core Technique, Energizer, has been activated.]

[The double circle's efficiency has been brought to the max.]

[You will never get tired for the next ten minutes.]

Time to dig! Scoop! Thwack! Fwoosh! His shoveling looked like a frenzied dance.

Each time Lloyd dug, a bucketful of earth got excavated, and a pit appeared in no time.

It was knee-deep at first. Next, it was waist-deep, and at last, it was deeper than Lloyd's height.

Once he was done with the depth, he changed the direction of the shoveling.

It's time to make a tunnel! The skill lasted only for ten minutes, but it was enough to dig a tunnel that would lead them out of the wall.

Lloyd moved forward, his shoveling full of pizzazz and fierceness. Javier, on the other hand, quietly stayed behind. Staring at Lloyd's back, he thought to himself. *He looks like a mole cricket. I'm going to remember this and use it against him next time. If he makes fun of me, I'm going to shoot back at him with this someday.*

Javier wrote this expression in his head and he simultaneously looked around lest the sorcerer attack them from the top of the tunnel.

A few minutes later, "Hey." Lloyd called.

"Come over here. Stab to the side, and boom, mana blast. Got it?"

“What about your eardrum?”

“It’s fine. You’re not hitting the metal anyway.”

“Yes.” Javier nodded.

Now that they passed the metal wall through the underground tunnel Lloyd instantly made, it was time for them to come up to the ground. Of course, the surfacing part had to be quick and forceful. They needed to catch the sorcerer unprepared.

“Please step back.”

Once Javier checked that Lloyd was at a safe distance, he held up his sword. He pulled and stabbed.

Swoosh!

At the same time, the three circles spun around his heart at an incredible speed. The circles began to spin at opposite angles and two circles closed in on each other at lightning speed, finally causing a giant collision.

The shockwave spread from the heart and raced along the veins.

It amplified as it traveled to the muscles and reached the sword after navigating through his elbow, wrist, and fingers. It then spurted out from the tip of the sword and exploded.

Boom! The explosion boomed in a vertical direction, and the earth evaporated out of thin air, creating a thirty-feet hole that led to the ground.

“Let’s go! Quick!”

Lloyd, who was covering his ears, yelled. Two of them bolted up to the ground, like two fierce animals escaping out of a zoo. The dark sorcerer’s eyes snapped open in pure panic when he saw them.

“Eek! What the!”

He had complete trust in his defensive posture but it got neutralized so easily.

He couldn’t believe it. *No way. That silver-haired guy is the one that didn’t make it through the entrance a few days ago!* In fact, he had been keeping a close eye on the situation ever since Javier tried to enter the dungeon.

It had been a while since the dungeon had a visitor. Though Javier walked away because of the magic circles at the entrance, the sorcerer figured that he mustn’t be overlooked. Why? Because Javier didn’t die after being hit by the magic circle, the dark sorcerer thought to himself that this intruder would show up soon.

My prediction was right.

So he began to work. After he was left alone, he ramped up the defenses in the dungeon by doubling the number of magic circles.

That gave him some relief and he thought that he was safe now. He realized that he was wrong. The silver-haired man appeared with someone else, and this time, they managed to encroach into the deepest part of the dungeon. Even worse, they didn’t even activate a single magic circle on their way!

He was shocked. The intrusion was made plain to him only after they made inroads into the dungeon. He didn’t know because they avoided all the magic circles. So, he proceeded to use his last resort for defense.

The metal walls had shot down from the ceiling to trap them, and then a deadly gas was released.

And yet! They managed to bypass that! These two just rose from underground. It turned out they were no ordinary people. It was time to focus or he would lose. He immediately clasped his hands. “Yap!”

His laced hands formed a special shape. Some fingers were bent. Some were straightened.

Mana flowed following his hand signs, to be rearranged in a special pattern. A large four-inch dark magic circle appeared right in front of his hand. Then, he stretched out his hand.

“Take this!”

Swoosh! The magic circle jerked.

A mysterious liquid gushed out like a monster puking out acid.

Splash! The slimy liquid gushed forward, forming a straight line, directly to Javier. Just then, Javier wielded his sword and struck the air. From bottom to top his sword moved vertically, creating a force that shot straight ahead. When it met the gushing liquid, it split in half. The liquid parted by the sheer power of force.

When the liquid spluttered onto the rocks, they soon boiled and melted away. Meanwhile, Javier hurtled toward his opponent.

Kaboom!

The dark sorcerer’s eyes widened in shock. The magic he just cast was an acidic attack, so it couldn’t be protected. It was especially so for swords and shields. It had to be. *But he just slashed the liquid in half! With just a force he had created out of the blade! That’s possible? This is impossible. That silver-haired knight is ridiculous. Is he a sword master or something?!*

He concluded to himself that he could be a sword master. The knight was different from the rest of the sword experts he knew. However, this didn’t mean that he was going to give up now and surrender. Animosity flashed in his eyes.

“Argh!” He took a knee as he yelled viciously.

He widened his arms and touched the ground with his hands. His fingers dug into the earth.

The mana arrangement changed again depending on the angle and depth of his fingers in the earth. A new magic circle was formed on the ground.

Rumble! The black magic circle wriggled and seconds later, it trembled as it tapped the ground.*Bam!* A gray hand shot upward under the earth, grabbed Javier's ankle, and stopped him from charging at the sorcerer.

There was more. A second after Javier hesitated, dozens of hands popped out of the ground at the same time.

At first, it was the hand, then it was the wrist, the arms, the shoulders, and eventually, the rotten face.

"Kaaaak! Kwoop! Kaaaak!"

The ghouls thirsted for fresh human flesh.

"Kaaak!!"

Ghouls sprang up around Javier. There were fifty ghouls in total. So, Javier found himself besieged by these demonic monsters. The dark sorcerer started to smile at the sight.

Wahahahaha! These aren't just ordinary ghouls! They are different from the brainless and slow ordinary ghouls! I spent 100 days experimenting and strengthening my magic circle to create them! Their skins are granite-hard! They move like the wind! And they're absolutely obedient to me. And what ferocity they possess! Each ghoul is as strong as a death knight, and one can battle dozens of sword experts! This is my weapon, the powerful and…

Even before the dark sorcerer had the time to smile fully, a strong flash of light burst around Javier. It was followed by a deadly, chilly wind. The fifty ghouls rushing to him stopped dead in their tracks. They all made the same noise a second later.

"Ghoul?"

That was the end of them. *Thud, thud.* All of them were beheaded and their heads dropped to the floor followed by their arms, legs, waist, and then body. Each section of the body was cut one after another. These so-called enhanced ghouls collapsed like broken legos.

Thud. A cold silence fell over the dungeon. Javier lifted his head in silence, and his cynical gaze moved to the dark sorcerer.

“Do you have any more friends to invite?”

At that moment, the dark sorcerer despaired. *I’m going to die today.*

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Chapter 38: True Repentance (3)

“Uhm...Uhm...”

The dark sorcerer, Lupellan, retreated. His heart pounded violently and fear crept into his heart. He wanted to run away but it was impossible.

Step. Step. Javier, the silver-haired knight, was slowly walking toward him. His gaze didn’t leave Lupellan for even a second. *He will raise his sword at me if I try anything.* Lupellan sensed it. The silver-haired knight would wield his sword the moment he tried to run away.

He would never be able to avoid or block the blow. The wizard couldn’t even dare to think of fighting back.

This was all because he was out of mana. *Who would have thought he’d wipe out the enhanced ghouls so easily...*Lupellan never imagined it. The ghouls were made out of various potions and dark magic. He had specially processed the magic circle, which took him over a hundred days of working day and night to design. So the enhanced ghouls boasted strength that was incomparable to their ordinary counterparts. Their steel-like skin even bounced off axes and their movement was swift like the wind.

Furthermore, they were also fairly intelligent. Combined with their ferocity, even Lupellan was chilled to the bones in their presence. In short, these enhanced ghouls were the perfect killing machine, the ultimate weapon in Lupellan’s arsenal. But who was this silver-haired knight in front of him? What kind of knight could slash through fifty enhanced ghouls in one sweep and turn them into rotten meat?

“You! Who in the world are you?!” Lupellan snarled, resentful.

The veins behind his neck popped.

“Why in the world are you throwing a fit here?”

He found himself yelling in fear, resentment, and desperation. On one end, it was his outcry of self-resignation. He sensed it, too. He sensed that his death was near. *I don't want to die.*

He wanted to live. There was research he direly wanted to complete successfully. He had to finish it. That was how he could save his lost family and how he could restore his happy past.

That belief was what kept Lupellan going every day. The approaching silver-haired knight looked like a grim reaper.

Tap. Tap. Javier's steps gradually narrowed their distance one by one. There was no escape or opportunity to fight back. What's worse was that Javier was coming near without uttering a single word. This meant that there was no room for negotiation. Zero. That realization drove the dark sorcerer into a panic.

"Stop! Don't come near! Don't come near!" Lupellan screeched, but it was in vain.

The silver-haired knight's blue eyes flashed with murderous animosity.

His sword emitted light and swished in the air. *Slash!*

"Eek...!"

Lupellan squeezed his eyes shut.

Just then, "Javier, stop."

An unexpected voice spoke. At the same time, a soft breeze touched the back of his neck.

Whew.

Was I beheaded? Lupellan carefully opened his eyes. Then, once again, he shrieked aloud.

He realized that the silver-haired knight’s sword was just an inch away from his neck.

“Ha...Whew!”

His legs wobbled and his body lost strength. Just then, a voice, which sounded like a lifeline, was heard again.

“Don’t kill him just yet, Javier. I have something to do first.”

Who could it be? Lupellan wondered. His gaze moved over to the source. There was a man with black hair. Feeling the sorcerer’s gaze, Lloyd scoffed and said, “I have something to discuss with him, so put the sword away.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

Javier removed the sword and Lupellan heaved a sigh. Lloyd walked over to him and said, “Hey, are you all right?”

Lupellan wondered what in the world Lloyd meant when both of them had just fought with swords and magic just a few minutes ago. He didn’t consider Lloyd brazen and regardless, Lloyd was his savior. Lupellan carefully said, “Whew...Whew...It is fine. Anyway, thank you very much for having mercy and sparing me.”

“Mercy? Ha.” Lloyd snickered.

He didn’t save this black sorcerer because he felt merciful. He did so because the sorcerer was useful. It was plain and simple, everything he had done up to this point was for retaliation. Now, it was time for exploitation. At the same time, it was playtime for Lloyd. Going over the plans in his head, Lloyd said, “Mercy...You know, I am not that kind.”

“Anyway, you kidnapped my soldiers and stole my construction supplies. Am I wrong?”

“Uhm...Are you talking about the men I took here a few days ago?”

“Yeah. Are they alive?”

“Yes, they are.”

“Everyone?”

“Yes,” said Lupellan.

“That’s great. Because I was going to kill you immediately if something happened to even one of them.”

Lloyd grinned. The corners of Lupellan’s eyes flinched slightly.

“Uhm...Uhm...You see, I am sorry.”

“Sorry? That’s it?”

“Of course not.”

Lupellan shook his head in a hurry.

“I shall let them go immediately. So, would it be alright if I move for a moment?”

“Be my guest.” Lloyd permitted.

Lupellan carefully rose from the ground. He walked over to a corner of the laboratory and pulled down the lever. *Clank! Clank!* A metallic noise rang several times and at last, the wooden wall on the side of the lab opened and revealed a prison hidden behind it.

“Tsk, tsk.” Lloyd scowled when he saw the inside.

He couldn’t help himself.

“Look at them. They’ve become emaciated.”

It was true. The soldiers looked terribly sick. There were twenty in total. Ten had been sent back by Lloyd to bring the insulation materials. Another ten, Lloyd assumed, were sent by the fiefdom. The cavernous eyes and

protruded cheekbones of the men behind the cell indicated that they had starved.

“I...I apologize.”

“You think an apology would cut it? What were you going to do if they died in there?”

Lupellan became silent.

“You know, I’m starting to get curious. What are you? A pervert? Just what were you planning on doing with them by locking them up?”

“Be honest with me now. It looks like you have your own reasons.”

Lloyd’s tone strangely sounded like a nag and encouragement at the same time. Perhaps that was the reason why Lupellan slowly spoke up after opening and closing his lips in hesitation.

“In fact...Uhm...I was...researching how to bring back the dead.”

“Bring back the dead? Do you mean the undead?”

Lloyd turned to look at what was left of the enhanced ghouls. Lupellan shook his head.

“No, it’s not that. I wasn’t researching the undead. That’s different.”

“Different? What’s the difference?”

“I researched how to bring back those that simply just passed away.”

“Those that passed away? Do you mean resurrection?”

“Resurrection...Yes. It is something like that.”

Lupellan nodded in a hurry.

“I wanted to bring back my family. I mean my wife and children...”

“Why? Did something happen to them?”

“Yes,” replied Lupellan.

For the first time since they met, his voice sounded sad.

“I used to be a sorcerer in an ordinary fiefdom. I had a typical family with a wife and children. I was happy. No, I would have continued to be happy if it weren’t for that awful accident...”

“Stop there. If you’re trying to narrate a tedious story of what happened with every detail, don’t bother.”

“Anyway...I wanted to bring back my family. That’s why I did it.”

“That’s why you researched magic down here?”

“Yeah.”

“Tell me, do you have to sacrifice living souls in order to bring back the dead?”

“That’s...”

“You have to.”

Lloyd’s eyes narrowed to slits.

“And it looks like you’ve tried it out several times already. Am I right?”

The dark sorcerer grew silent and Lloyd’s voice grew edgier.

“You’ve been researching forbidden magic. I presume you have sacrificed dozens of people already.”

“That’s...”

“Shut your mouth, please. Do you know what you’ve done?”

His edgy voice was now becoming rough.

“Bring back the dead? Do you think that’s remotely possible? Use common sense, you idiot.”

“I just...”

“Shut it. Fine. Let’s say that you did it. Let’s say for a second that this outrageous attempt works, and you bring back your wife and children. Do you really think they would thank you for saving them? Wait, yeah. They might. After all, birds of a feather flock together. Maybe not your children, but your wife.”

“Please don’t speak ill of my wife and children.”

“You made me speak ill of them.”

“Why? Don’t you like hearing it? Are you upset? But you have nothing to say, right?”

“Do you now see what you’ve done? Foolish idiot. The dead are dead. It’s courteous of you to let them be at peace once they’re gone.”

At that moment, Lloyd wrinkled his nose. It must be because he remembered his parents.

Lupellan bit his lips. “Of course, I...I know that. But I cannot forget my beloved wife and my children, who were more important than life itself. How can I move on so easily? No matter if I close or open my eyes, they never leave my sight for a second. I cannot bear it.”

“So, you’re saying that’s why you weren’t able to move on?”

“It’s my fault. I know that. I know it’s my greed and foolishness.”

“So? What are you going to do from now on?”

“Forget them...What else can I do?”

Hot tears started to slide down Lupellan’s cheeks. Instead of wiping the tears off, he stared at Lloyd, his eyes red.

“I’m going to stop this research.”

“Really? Are you really going to stop it?”

“Yes. Actually, I am...tired as well.”

“Tsk. You should have grown tired sooner.”

“You can accuse me a hundred times, and I’m still guilty. So in return...”

Lupellan looked away and at the end of his gaze was a huge metal box.

Pointing at the box, he said, “I’m going to give you everything in that box.”

“That one? What’s that?”

“It contains the magical potions and items I’ve garnered to conduct my research.”

“Hmm...It must be expensive.”

“They mean nothing to me anymore.”

“I guess you really made a decision...”

“I don’t have another choice, do I? Here, take this. I’ll open the box for you.”

The black sorcerer walked over to the box. He then bit the end of his index finger in front of it and brought his bleeding finger into its keyhole. The blood soaked into the hole.

“This is a magical lock. It opens up only by my blood. My blood that is spilled when I am alive, that is. Otherwise, even a slight push from the outside melts every item in the box.”

He must have been telling the truth because the box clunked open. Inside, Lloyd saw that the box contained a variety of magic potions, ingredients, and goods, all compressed together.

“This is my way of compensating you for all the damage I’ve caused by kidnapping your men. Please accept it.”

“If you insist.”

Lloyd smiled in satisfaction and Lupellan smiled bitterly. At last, he brought his hand up to wipe the tears off his eyes and when his face was covered by the sleeve, he raised the corners of his lips. *You fool.* The dark sorcerer smiled. He was extremely relieved that this young man was fooled.

I’m so relieved that this young gentleman thinks himself smart. Plus, this man was slightly greedy and kind at the same time. Thanks to it, Lupellan pretended to be contrite and managed to be forgiven. *Yes, it worked. I can collect magical items anytime. I can always make potions again, too. What matters most is getting out of here alive.* Regardless of what he had to give, the most important thing was to stay alive. Afterward, he would resume his research somewhere else. This time, he would work even harder to complete his theory.

Then I’ll be able to bring them back. My wife and kids...We’ll meet again. The mere thought of it touched his heart. His heart trembled in sorrow and he wished to leave this place immediately and get back to his research. *I’ll increase the scale of my research. Make it bolder. I’ll sacrifice hundreds, not dozens. That would up my success rate. And after that, I’ll be able to get back my happiness and return to the good days.* Lupellan clenched his fists.

He told himself that it was time to say goodbye to this young gentleman as he fooled the latter enough.

He could simply leave this dungeon, pretending to be touched and satisfied.

“I shall...leave now.”

“Where are you going?”

“I do not know yet. I am thinking of wandering around until I find land suitable for farming.”

“I see, that doesn’t sound like a bad idea.”

“Thank you. So long.” Lupellan then gave Lloyd a slight bow. With a sorrowful and serious look on his face, he turned around.

No, he was about to when...

“Javier. Let me ask you one thing.”

Lloyd’s cold voice rang.

“How are serial killers dealt with by the royal law?”

“If the murders were clearly done in bad faith, and when there are objective pieces of evidence, testimonies, confessions, ten or more witnesses to back those murders, a noble is allowed by law to execute them on the spot.”

Javier’s sharp answer rang aloud in the place.Lupellan flinched in surprise.

“What? What do you mean?”

Chills ran down his spine. *Immediate execution? What’s he saying? Everyone was in a good mood just a minute ago.* Lupellan wondered what prompted a change in the young man’s attitude. *Swish.* Javier drew his sword.

Sensing that this was not a joke, Lupellan hurried, “Why? Why?”

He frantically stepped back.

Looking at Lloyd, he asked, “Are you really going to kill me? Why? Why?”

“What do you mean, why? Isn’t it obvious?”

“Obvious? I don’t get it...”

“Didn’t you just hear? You’re a serial killer.” Lloyd emphasized.

The way Lloyd looked at Lupellan was completely devoid of the naivety that was there a while ago. There was only a cold, bitter expression. Lupellan’s heart grew desperate.

“But, I repented enough, and...I even acknowledged my fault...”

“So?” Lloyd asked.

“I even shed tears! I shed tears as I repented my sins!”

“Crying makes you all okay? Do your sins go away by being contrite about them?”

“That’s...”

“Hey, please, quit your drivel.”

Lloyd snickered in disbelief.

“I thought I told you a while ago. You did all this for your family? To bring back your beloved wife and children? But what about those that died in your hands? Do you think they didn’t have any families? Do you think they didn’t have their own life?”

“Please, you shouldn’t have covered up your sins with your forced repentance or pretended to be penitent. Did you think I’d be fooled by that? You have no idea how many times I’ve met people like you.”

Lloyd’s voice sounded stern. Suddenly, he called to mind his life back in South Korea.

The news was flooded with heinous criminals every day. People kidnapped, raped, killed, and did entirely inhumane things. *But barely did they pay for what they’ve done*.

That was because of the country’s justice system. Something was off in the system. Heinous criminals got off cheap, receiving only light sentences.

Some pleaded to the judge that it was a drunken mistake. Some claimed to be mentally ill. Others begged the judge that they were genuinely sorry for what they did and the judges sentenced them magnanimously, spewing some outrageous excuses. Each time he watched the events unfold, Lloyd genuinely wondered if the judges had truly gone mad. He had seen plenty of such cases and so, he was able to see through the dark sorcerer's tricks. All this while, he was just dancing to the latter's tune.

It was so I could get a hold of those magical supplies. Lloyd stole a glance at the box.

To be frank, it was the reason he had temporarily postponed killing him. That was also one of the reasons why he painstakingly worked his way into this dungeon with Javier. Now that he got what he wanted, Lloyd didn't need Lupellan anymore. He wanted to take care of this criminal as harshly as possible. *I can forgive him, but he won't learn from his mistakes. It's the same in the novel. He gets forgiven by Javier, only to strike back and get his head sliced off.*

It was true. As such, Lloyd was convinced that this dark sorcerer would only take his research somewhere else and massacre hundreds.

"So, I'll summarize things for you. You can exaggerate your stories and give me those crocodile tears of yours, but there's something that won't change. It's your character. Do you know what that is?"

"That you are a serial killer."

"And a serial killer must pay for his sin. It's only right," Lloyd announced.

"Hold on!"

"Javier, do as the law says," Lloyd spoke and turned around.

Lupellan frantically pleaded, asking for mercy. Javier stepped forward as he drew his sword.

“I, Knight Javier Asrahan, am here to execute the holy law of the kingdom under the order of Lloyd Frontera, the son of Baron Frontera.”

Swish. Javier mercilessly flourished his sword.

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Chapter 39: The Friend of the Orc Tribe (1)

The dark sorcerer was dead, but Lloyd didn’t directly watch it happen. Regardless of his new life, he was still Suho Kim on the inside. He certainly didn’t wish to see someone die.

One time is enough experience. He suddenly recalled the last memory of his parents.

Crinkling his nose, Lloyd brushed the thoughts away and came back to reality.

“Hey, hey. Be careful, everyone. Don’t take your eyes off the ground and step on a weird spot. And make sure to look for any rocks, you might trip yourselves.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

The isolation and hunger had weakened the soldiers. Leading them out of the dungeon took a great toll on Lloyd. It was because of the magical traps that still lingered in the cave.

A few hours later, everyone was able to get out safely. Lloyd then told Javier to go in and take the items from the laboratory. Javier did more than what he was asked of by bringing out the insulation material the dark sorcerer had stacked in the corner of the lab. However, Lloyd still had another problem to solve because the soldiers were in terrible condition.

“Whew! These guys are just seconds away from fainting. Hey, give that to me.”

“Eh?! Master Lloyd?”

“What? Give them to me now.”

Lloyd was referring to the wheat straws that would insulate the seokbinggo. The soldier was tottering down the range because of the straws that heavily

weighed down on his back. Lloyd casually walked over and yanked them into his arms. The soldier gazed at Lloyd in utter embarrassment as the weight on his back was snatched away.

“Young Master...! I should be carrying that. I cannot let a noble like yourself take the burden...”

“Oh, really? I’m just scared that you will pass out and force me to carry you as well.”

“I will not pass out.”

“You know that’s not true.”

“You are pale as a sheet. Do you know that?”

“That’s...”

“I told you already. It’s fine. Your late arrival already delayed the construction way too much. If you collapse right now, we’ll have to walk slower to take care of you. Am I wrong or what?” asked Lloyd.

“I’m not doing this because I like you. Don’t get the wrong idea.”

“Ah...I understand.”

“If you do, make sure you don’t fall behind. Here we go!” Lloyd shouted and slung the bundle of straws over to his back.

Without waiting for the soldier to respond, Lloyd turned and moved to the tail of the procession. He then set off, keeping pace with the slowest soldier. But of course, he didn’t show this directly. Instead, he verbally harassed the soldier throughout the trip.

“Hey, why do you keep glancing at me?”

“No, I didn’t, Young Master.”

“Like I would believe that. I saw you clearly stealing a glance at me.”

“Please forgive me.”

“You think you’re excused if you apologize? What are you, a civilian?”

“Of course not.”

“Why are you so stiff?”

“Goodness. I’m scared that you’ll tear up if I keep teasing you. Forget it. Let’s just keep walking.”

Even after that, Lloyd continued to verbally harass his soldiers while taking the burdens from the exhausted ones. This process was repeated over and over again throughout the trip.

“Ha, walking was comparatively easier today. I think it’s thanks to Master Lloyd.”

“Right? It was the same for me yesterday.”

“Hey, me too. I was so grateful to him.”

Late at night, the soldiers gathered up at the temporary campsite. Fearing that their voices could be heard, they gossiped with one another.

“But really, do you think the young master came here to rescue us?” a soldier asked.

“Doesn’t it look like that?”

“Well, I think he was also motivated to take back the insulation materials.”

“Even so, he came for us, and that’s what matters. I thought I was really going to die in there.”

“You’re right. I thought so, too.”

The soldiers were deeply grateful to Lloyd for saving them. Their feelings of gratitude amplified when they heard Javier’s advice.

“You should be feeling more than grateful. All of you must live indebted to Master Lloyd for the rest of your life.”

“Eh? Sir Asrahan?!”

The soldiers tensed up at Javier’s unexpected presence.

Javier impassively went on, “I had recommended Master Lloyd to go back to the fiefdom first, gear up, and fight the dark sorcerer. But he didn’t listen to me. He was worried that you all might die before then. That’s why he threw himself into the cave when it was just the two of us.”

A heavy silence fell among them.

“If it weren’t for his decision, you all would have starved to death or been sacrificed as an offering in the hands of the dark sorcerer. Remember that for the rest of your lives.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

The soldiers were deeply touched. It was Sir Asrahan who was telling the story.

A man who never exaggerated or groveled. Since he was a faithful, just, and objective man, everyone could trust his story without any doubt. *I cannot believe Master Lloyd did that for us*...He was once considered a hooligan and was at the center of countless gossip.

People talked ill of him behind his back, including them.

Yet, the same man now risked his own life and put himself in harm’s way to save them, some low-rank soldiers. Profoundly touched by his sacrifice, the soldiers secretly wiped their tears off in front of the bonfire. They joked to themselves that it was the smoke of the fire and laughed foolishly. A sense of profound gratitude was deeply engraved upon their heart.

Thanks to that, a new message popped in front of Lloyd.

Ding Dong.

[The rescued soldiers are deeply moved by your actions.]

[Although they are the only ones touched at the moment, the soldiers will spread your heroic story once they are back in the fiefdom. This may eventually lead to social achievement.]

Oh, this is good. Lloyd exclaimed internally.

He was grateful that he managed to save his men and acquire precious magic materials.

Moreover, he managed to safely return to the orc village after retrieving all the insulation materials he needed to build a seokbinggo.

As soon as he arrived at the village, he got to work to finish the last part of the construction. *There's nothing more terrible than delaying the construction schedule!* Constructing something was always a struggle with time. The longer the construction period was delayed, the higher the costs were.

"So we must move super quick. I wasn't there, so you guys got to rest for the past few days, right?"

Lloyd encouraged the soldiers who stayed behind in the village by taking off his clothes and sweating hard as he instructed everyone on the site. He added water to the mud mixed with limestone. Then, he mixed the rice husks, wheat straws, and sawdust in the right proportion. Afterward, he mixed all the ingredients with water until it thickened like porridge. This type of insulation was inspired by the urethane foam used back in South Korea on construction sites. But it was made out of natural ingredients here.

This will do. He then stuffed the natural, handmade insulation in the empty spaces between the limestone bricks and the ground, pressing down every inch to ensure it was airtight.

He did the same with the arch ceiling.

"Okay, make sure that it's airtight! Fill it as much as you can!"

“Yes!”

Lloyd shouted, and the soldiers resonated in unison. The outside of the ceiling got coated with a thick layer of insulation batter. It was topped again with another thick layer of the limestone and mud mixture, which would prevent any liquid from spilling in from above.

After that, the structure was topped with one more thick layer of soil, making it look like a mound. Once it was done, only the tip of the chimney slightly protruded out of the mound.

Lloyd then covered the chimney with rocks and densely planted wild sandburs around the area.

There should be a thick carpet of grass to keep off the sun’s radiant heat.

The grass would be the first line of defense against the heat. Its roots would absorb the moisture that may seep below.

“Whew, this is the last of the sandbur.”

Lloyd removed his shovel. He placed the hunk of sandbur he had plucked along with its root at the top of the mound. Flattening it with his shovel, Lloyd made sure to sprinkle some water on the grass.

That would help the roots grow into the soil and with that last act of shoveling, the seokbinggo was finished. However, there still was another job that needed to be done.

“Oink?! My savior has finished the seokbinggo. But it’s not as cool here as I heard it would be, oink.”

Arosh had rushed to the site, the hairs in his nostrils swaying against the wind, when he heard that the construction was done. Arosh’s pecs burned in excitement as he thought about how the facility’s cold atmosphere would allow them to preserve their food. When he set foot in the seokbinggo, he was surprised. The inside wasn’t as cool as he expected.

“What happened? It’s not very cool here, oink.” “Right? It’s only a bit cooler than the outside, where the scorching sun is beating down. So it makes sense that you’re confused.”

“Yes, it’s only slightly cooler than outside, and I can’t tell if there’s a big difference, oink.”

Orc Arosh tilted his large head as he was slightly disappointed. However, he had trust in his savior. Until now, Lloyd always forged something fascinating, so Arosh trusted that his savior would have a plan this time, too. His expectation was proved to be correct.

“You’re right. It’s not cool here. Not yet.”

“Not yet, oink?”

“Uh-huh. A seokbinggo needs ice, but there isn’t any here.”

“Ice? Do you mean it will get cold if you put ice in here, oink?”

“Of course. Even if it’s a seokbinggo, the facility can’t cool down by itself. Similar to how an icebox wouldn’t get cold without ice.”

“Ice...box? Oink?”

“Yeah, it’s something similar.”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about. Anyway, where do you plan on getting the ice, oink?”

“There is no way to get them. I mean, ordinarily, there isn’t one.”

“Ordinarily, oink?”

“Uh-huh. We’re in the middle of summer.”

“Aha, oink.”

That was when it dawned on Arosh that the scorching sun was shining brightly outside right now. Forget about the ice. It was so hot that he was worried the creek would dry up.

Arosh's nostrils flared.

"But it looks like you have a plan. Am I correct? Oink?"

"You're right."

Lloyd grinned.

"Since I can't get ice the normal way, I'll make them myself and pack them here," Lloyd announced.

"Make ice? How, oink?"

"How else? I should do it very well."

They were in the middle of summer. They obviously had no place to acquire ice. They weren't in the place to reach out to a sorcerer who uses ice magic, either. So there was only one option left: To make ice himself.

I have the Asrahan Core Technique, after all. Lloyd believed that he could make ice if he used the technique properly. Once the plan was made in his head, he got to work right away.

First, he fed a red sunflower seed to Ppodong. Once the hamster grew gigantic, Lloyd asked, "Hey, Ppodong?"

"Ppodong?"

"Do you know the creek over there in the mountain range?"

"Ppodong!"

"Yeah, that's the place. Would you kindly go and fetch water from there?"

"Ppo-do-dong?"

“As much as your cheeks can hold on both sides. Can you do it?”

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!”

“Oh, why don’t you take Bangul with you on your way? Bangul, eat this sunflower seed. Here you go.”

“Bangul!”

Boom! Bangul grew gigantic after eating the red sunflower seed. Ppodong rode the transformed Bangul on his back.

“Bangul, fetch a huge bucket of water for me. But don’t make them into steel poops. Tense up your buttocks when you want to, and hold it in a little. Okay?”

“Bangul!”

The two giants waddled as they ran off. Sometime later, they came back, with each holding a huge volume of water in their cheeks and belly.

“Good job! Will you spit it in here?”

“Ppodung? Blergh!”

“Bungul! Blergh!”

The two summons vomited water on the rock mold. The mold, which Lloyd had made prior, became filled up with water.

This is like a gigantic version of the ice cube mold that you put in freezers.

Lloyd created them using the granite that was left over from building the seokbinggo. He meticulously chiseled the rough edges every time he had the chance to. The final output reminded him of the ice mold that was commonly seen in South Korean homes, only this one was larger. The ice molds, which were divided into sections, were transferred into the seokbinggo by the soldiers and Lloyd himself. Afterward, Lloyd sent everyone out. He closed the door, and he was the only one left in there.

Let’s get started.

Lloyd moved to the corner of the seokbinggo. He brought the pile of wheat straws and stuffed them into the lapping water.

Then, he fixed the straws at the bottom and to the sides of the mold by tightly pressing them. This preparation would allow him to conveniently remove the ice safely without damaging it if the water froze later on. So, Lloyd meticulously carpeted the straws around the inside of the ice mold. After that, everything was set. He got to make the ice right away.

Okay, time to focus.

He sat cross-legged in front of the ice mold. After rolling up his sleeves, he put his arms into the water. He calmed his heart to concentrate and then activated the Asrahan Core Technique.

Ziiing…

The two quiet mana circles began to rotate like a car engine. Two circles began to rotate around the center, their absorption power revving up. The power expanded as it traveled across Lloyd’s veins and muscles. Past his shoulders, it went down to the arms and fingertips. The mana near the fingertips began to get absorbed. This process was typical of the Asrahan Core Technique. Lloyd, however, was attempting a different variation.

I don’t need to absorb all the mana, just the warm ones.

He absorbed it slowly. At first, it didn’t go as well as he had hoped as the rotation of the mana circles destabilized at times because he wasn’t familiar with this application method. However, Lloyd didn’t give up.

Slowly and carefully, with more focus, he strove to single out only the warm mana floating around the water.

He engrossed himself in the process for a very long period of time.

One hour...Two hours...Then three hours passed by… Just then, the water began to change.

*Fwish...Fwish...*The heat, or the warm mana, started to grow faint. The water began to grow cooler and the thin layers of ice started to form. At the same moment, a message popped into his head. *Ding Dong.*

[You have developed a new application for the Asrahan Core Technique.]

[Your skill level of the Asrahan Core Technique has increased because of your notable effort.]

Ice making—the last procedure in the seokbinggo construction. Lloyd's research and effort helped him level up in the technique.

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Chapter 40: The Friend of the Orc Tribe (2)

Ding Dong.

[Skill Level Up!]

[The Asrahan Core Technique: Double Circle Lv. 2]

[Mana amplified to: 220%]

[Skill Options: 1. Energizer / 2. Latent Power Surge / 3. Power Saving Mode]

[Required RP to level up: 120]

The message rang clear in his ears. He exclaimed under his breath as he heard it.

It's working. The ice is freezing. And I just leveled up. This was what Lloyd had hoped would happen. His novel attempt to freeze the water by using the Asrahan Core Technique and absorbing the warm mana looked like a great training exercise.

He became hopeful, and he was spot on. *This is way better than I had expected.* He could feel the warm mana flowing into his fingertips as he dipped his hands in the water. The task was challenging at first because he wasn't used to it. But once he got the hang of it, it became easy. It felt like he had just succeeded in riding a bike for the first time. *Okay, time to ramp up the force.*

Crackle…

The two mana circles around his heart gradually rotated at a faster speed.

The absorption power in his fingertips started to get more forceful. More heat flowed into his hand. The freezing speed increased as well. *I need to make sure that my hands won't get stuck in the ice.* The water was freezing

up like a slushie. Lloyd slowly pulled his hands out until only his fingertips kissed the surface.

The heat absorption continued. The heat was then processed in the mana circles and belched through his mouth. His breathing was hot as it puffed from his mouth. It was because of the heat he was absorbing. *Hmm. I look a bit like a chimney, but whatever.*

What he looked like wasn't important and as such, Lloyd continued to employ the technique. Finally, he succeeded in creating a huge block of ice.

"Whew."

He pulled his hands out and he opened his eyes. The water that lapped in the mold some hours ago was now frozen solid.

Good. I succeeded. Lloyd lifted his head and looked at the ceiling.

He could feel the heat flowing in the air as he used the Asrahan Core Technique. *The heat is traveling out of here.* Lloyd could sense that the heat from the hot water was traveling out through the arch ceiling and chimney. The hot air in the seokbinggo was leaving this place.

This was proof that the facility was a success.

Based on the light I can see through the chimney, it looks like it's evening now. Lloyd had entered here alone slightly after lunchtime. But it was dinner time after making one block of ice. *I'm so slow. At this rate, it's going to be my sixtieth birthday when I walk out of here after I finish making all the ice.* Thinking that he should speed things up, Lloyd sat in front of the next ice mold.

He breathed in and out and put his hands in the water. There was slightly more boldness in his movement and he employed the new technique. *Crackle...! Oh, it's working.* Just a few minutes in, he sensed the water growing slightly cooler. *A bit faster.* He revved up the rotation speed of his mana circles. The absorbing power, which Lloyd concentrated at his fingertips, got enhanced by another notch. The water was cooling up

quickly, and in seconds, a sheet of thin ice formed on the surface. Its texture was similar to a slushie, and it later hardened into a thick block of ice.

Good. Let's keep going! The second ice took about an hour.He was getting the hang of it and he was getting confident. He jumped right onto the next ice mold. This ice block was made more quickly than the previous one.

*About forty minutes had passed.*The ice-making went on and the production time gradually decreased. The next large block of ice took about thirty minutes. The next one was done in twenty-five minutes and another finished in twenty.

Eventually, a block of ice was created within fifteen minutes. *Huff, huff. I need to go on!*

Lloyd absorbed the heat with his hands and exhaled the warm air through his mouth.

He felt like he had become a human air conditioner. The ice-making task continued through the night. Lloyd toiled until he was finished freezing the last ice mold, and it was already dawn.

"Whew! Ha..."

The prolonged usage of the technique must have taken a toll on him. The world spun around him when he rose. Even so, he felt it was worth it. *My skill leveled up again for the technique.* It happened when he was finishing up the last block of ice. The Asrahan Core Technique skill increased to double circle level three. The amplification rate increased to a whopping 240 percent. *Anyway, I'm finally done with the construction.* Lloyd looked around the seokbinggo with a satisfied expression. The warmth Arosh had complained about the previous day was completely gone. The blocks of ice were giving off cold air, so the whole space was very chilly. It was so cold that Lloyd could see his breath in the air like it was the middle of winter.

Okay, time to wrap things up. He was a bit tired but couldn't rest yet. Once again, he used the Asrahan Core Technique. *This time, just normal strength. Here I go! Tug!* Lloyd grabbed the strands of straws protruding out of the

ice molds. When he slowly pulled them up, the block of ice got dragged out of the mold with a cracking noise.

Lloyd then placed it on the thick straw mat he had made in advance. Once it was done, he generously plastered sawdust and rice husks on all sides, finishing off by sticking dry stalks on the top and sides of the structure. He was adding a separate layer of insulation on the ice itself to make sure that it would not melt. The process was repeated until every single ice block was pulled out of the mold and tightly wrapped in straw. Afterward, he stacked one after another to protect the chill chair. *Good. The ice will last until the winter.* Lloyd's face, which was marred with exhaustion, beamed in satisfaction. He was finally done with the seokbinggo. The time has come for him to be rewarded with plenty of treasures.

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"Oink! It's really cool, oink!"

"Oink! It's chilly, oink!"

"Oink! Even the ice is delicious, oink!"

"There's a traitor here...Oink!"

It was pure chaos in the seokbinggo. The orcs' eyes widened in utter shock the moment they set foot in the seokbinggo to store the large monster they'd hunted recently. It was very cold inside. Chief Akush was surprised as well.

"I never imagined it would be this cool, oink."

Akush's widened eyes were filled with adoration as he looked around the seokbinggo.

Lloyd shrugged. "Does that mean you doubted my ability?"

"To be honest, yes. I expected this place to be comparable to a cool basement. But this is... Oink."

“This is nothing to be impressed with. Just make sure that you keep the doors locked and protected. Make sure it’s tightly shut during the summer, but leave it open in the winter to let the cold breeze in.”

Apart from this, Lloyd taught the orcs how to preserve the ice and how to acquire it during the winter and put it in there. He imparted the orcs with useful knowledge about how to run the seokbinggo. Perhaps that was why the next thing happened.

“Truly, oink.”

Akush placed his pot-sized palm on Lloyd’s shoulder. His eyes contained trust that transcended the differences between them.

“Under this low temperature, we can certainly store meat until the winter. Human Lloyd, I truly thank you. You not only saved my son but solved my tribe’s unsolvable problem. You are a true friend and warrior, oink.”

“Does this mean that you will accept me as your warrior?”

“Of course, oink.”

“Even when I can’t do the leg workout using statues that only fat wild pigs...I mean, only you can carry?”

“That is correct, oink.” Chief Akush nodded his large head.

“We are friends from now on. You can be scrawny, bony, frail, soft, and incapable of doing the leg workout. You can also look like a delicate twig that’s about to snap. Even then, we will understand and accept you, oink.”

“Hey...Come on...”

“I am joking, hahaha, oink!”

Llyod and Akush roared in laughter. The former because he was dumbfounded, the latter because he was satisfied. Just then...

Ding Dong.

To his surprise, a new message popped in front of Lloyd.

[The orc race has opened up to you.]

[Orc tribal chief Akush has accepted you as his true friend.]

[The orcs now consider you as a friend on equal footing.]

[You can now increase your likeability through orcs and acquire RP.]

[One hundred RP has been rewarded for forming a new connection with another race.]

[Current RP: six hundred and eleven]

Huh? Lloyd opened his eyes wide. *I can now earn RP through orcs, too?* In truth, Lloyd wanted this to happen ever since he had saved Arosh. He wondered if he could be liked by the orcs and gain RP. But that didn't happen. He couldn't acquire RP from him for some reason. Not a single message about likeability popped up. That was the case even when Arosh considered him to be his savior. *So I just decided that it was impossible to earn RP from the orcs.* He had lowered his expectations with those thoughts in mind.

But now I know why. There was a reason why I couldn't obtain RP from him. It was because of the barrier between the two races. The two races had never formed a friendship before. That was why Lloyd couldn't acquire any RP from the orcs. Now, the limitation was gone. *What an unexpected gain.* Lloyd resolved to continue the friendship with the orcs even in the future. Of course, he didn't forget to collect the compensation he was offered now.

"I suppose it's time to fulfill the other agreements written in our contract," Lloyd said.

"Yes, since you built the seokbinggo for us, we will give our fitness tools to you, oink!!"

"And as stated in the contract, I will make new stone tools for you in return."

Lloyd didn’t need to do any extra work because he had been making fitness tools during the construction whenever he had the chance. Bangul pooped hunks of metal, and he linked them together to manufacture metal poles. Then for the weights, he used granite.

Just like that, massively heavy dumbbells, weights, and other tools were manufactured to be gifted to the orcs. In return, Lloyd received a large amount of gold, silver, and other expensive trinkets the orcs had been using to work out. There were more rewards.

“I, Arosh, made a promise to my savior, Lloyd! I agreed to send 120 orc men to the fiefdom once Lloyd is acknowledged as a warrior! I am a manly warrior, so I will uphold our promise today, oink!” Arosh’s shout rang aloud.

120 buff, muscular orc warriors stood in a line. They were those who volunteered to be deployed to the Frontera barony.

“Humans are weak, oink!”

“I want to teach them how to work out, oink!”

“We must go, oink!”

Just like that, 120 muscle evangelists, no, a deployment team was formed in one snap.

Lloyd smiled in satisfaction as he looked at them. *I had no idea that I’d gain this much.*

His friendship with the orcs paved the way for him to earn RP. The massive piles of gold and silver in the village became his possession.

Lloyd was now able to use 120 orc warriors as laborers. On top of everything, Lloyd had acquired valuable magic ingredients from the dark sorcerer. The more he thought about what he gained, the more content he became.

Good. Very good. The grand plan Lloyd had envisioned when he first met Arosh in the ant cave turned out to be modest. Something greater and more profitable than that had taken place.

“Let us get going right away.”

Everyone set off and left the village, receiving a fervent, enthusiastic farewell from the other orcs. The procession, which was supposedly composed of Lloyd, Javier, and forty civil engineering soldiers, was added with one hundred twenty orc warriors. The ground shook as the huge procession made its way over the range.

Despite the noise, everyone was safe from the threat of the monsters. That was because once the monsters noticed the one hundred twenty orcs grouped together, they sneaked out and took another path.

Sometimes, however, there were brave monsters that tried to attack Lloyd and his procession. But Javier and the orc warriors fought back and sliced them into tiny, minute-sized pieces. They instantly became a great source of protein for the orcs.

So everyone managed to cross the range without much difficulty. Even the large, heavy treasures posed no problem for anyone. It was because, in the first place, they were nothing but fitness tools for the orcs.

“Walking with these is really working me out, oink!”

“I am getting it! It’s stimulating my shoulders, oink!”

“My fat is burning, oink!”

These objects were heavy for ordinary humans. But orcs were different. They loved them.

They rejoiced that these treasures stimulated their muscles during their walk. They looked like buff, middle-aged gym addicts who shouted that there was nothing better in life than weightlifting. Sometimes, the orcs bickered and scrambled for heavier treasures among themselves. They

continued walking, chatting, and crossing over the range for ten days until, at last, a familiar landscape spanned in front of Lloyd.

It was the Frontera barony.He was home. However, when Lloyd entered his estate, he was met with a slightly unexpected turn of events.

“Master Lloyd, the baron is currently in the reception room.”

The housekeeper, who came to welcome Lloyd on behalf of the baron and baroness, bowed to Lloyd. Lloyd asked, “In the reception room? Are they with a guest?”

“Yes, Young Master,” the housekeeper replied.

“Who?”

“It’s...”

“It’s what?”

“Mister Shiloh and Meatloaf.”

“Who are they?”

“Uhm...They are the ones who lent the money to the baron...”

“Aha. The loan sharks?”

Lloyd remembered. The scrawny and fatty that visited the baron the last time.

He recalled how he had kicked them out of the estate by mixing up some lies and threats. Of course, with a dash of politeness. Calling to mind the past event, he smiled.

“Nice timing.”

He meant it. He had been meaning to meet with the loan sharks soon and go over the debt problem. *I think we click well together. I mean, they came to*

visit my house just when I needed them! I'm touched.

Lloyd headed toward the reception room. He couldn't help but hum as he thought about the deal he'd strike with those loan sharks.

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Chapter 41: The Friend of the Orc Tribe (3)

“I am home.”

Creak. Lloyd opened the door and spoke, forcing a calm tone.

The door opened to the inside of the reception room. Three people were gazing toward the door.

“Hmm? Lloyd?”

The first one to speak was Baron Frontera. His gaze was mixed with surprise, gladness, and a shade of embarrassment. Lloyd courteously paid his respect to the baron.

“Yes, I have returned.”

“Yes, I see you have returned safely. Everything is well with you? Are you hurt anywhere?”

“Yes. It’s all thanks to your concerns.”

“Still, you have grown thinner.”

“It’s nothing. Just hard travel over the mountains.”

Lloyd smiled bitterly. He was grateful that the baron asked how he was the moment they met. On the other hand, he felt relieved that he returned to the fiefdom at the most troubling time for the baron. Lloyd thought so because of the two unwelcome guests sitting across from the baron at the table.

“It’s been a while, Mr. Shiloh and Mr. Meatloaf.”

The two loan sharks kept staring at Lloyd without uttering a word.

Shilo was scrawny and Meatloaf was fat. The two looked at Lloyd with distaste.

It's probably because I kicked them out of the estate using my perfect logic the last time they were here. Lloyd seemed to be right about this assumption. Scrawny Shiloh rolled up a corner of his lips. "Oh, look who it is. It's the eldest son of Baron Frontera, the outstanding one."

"Indeed, he is. And what pretense did you bring today to kick us out?" Fatty Meatloaf seconded his partner's words.

Lloyd's bitter smile deepened as he heard them. "I suppose you have been properly invited today?"

"Of course," Shiloh answered.

"I sent a man to the baron in advance, asking if we could visit him. The wise baron happily agreed to see us. Isn't that true, Lord Frontera?"

"Yes...you are correct," the baron said and nodded.

But his face wasn't bright. It was obvious why. He had borrowed a hefty sum from these two so he couldn't dare stop them from visiting down here. Lloyd didn't need to hear the details to notice what was going on between them. After all, he was used to this kind of situation. *My father was the same.* The loan sharks came to Lloyd's house day after another.

His father suffered from endless harassment, but he dared not stop them. No matter what they said or did to him, he merely hung his head, seconding everything they said and repeating, "Yes, sir. Yes, sir."

Being powerless was a crime as the debtor was the sinner. Those were the words his father spewed in bitter lamentation as he emptied a bottle of *soju* the night the loan sharks turned the house upside down. *Whew. Stop thinking about it.* The mere recollection of those memories flooded Lloyd's heart with bitterness. Lloyd sucked in his breath and repressed those bitter memories. He stared at the two loan sharks in front of him. His gaze had already calmed down. Instead of painful memories, his eyes contained calm shrewdness. His voice was much the same.

“Haha. I see. I sincerely welcome you then. Have you been offered any drinks yet?”

“I don’t want drinks. I want something else.”

Scrawny Shiloh provocatively retorted. Fatty Meatloaf seconded his words again.

“For example, a mine.”

“A mine?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes, a mine,” Meatloaf spoke as his paunchy cheeks tumbled.

His eyes, which were buried under the fat around his eyes, flashed with greed. *Punk. The mine you constructed.* The idea had suddenly come to him. He remembered the coal mine constructed in the Frontera barony. People said that it was constructed by the soldiers, and it was led by the baron’s eldest son, the notorious brute. At first, Meatloaf didn’t believe it.

He didn’t believe the barony could ever build a mine. He scoffed and mocked that it was an impossibility because the barony wouldn’t have any money to construct one.

However, he was wrong as rumors of such kind continued to spread. They claimed that there was an accident during the mine drilling, wild ants almost got out of the caves, and the brutish young master achieved a heroic rescue to save everyone.

Rumors of all kinds spread one after another and reached Meatloaf’s ears. That was when things started to look odd, even for Meatloaf.

So he sent some people to look into the Frontera barony and see what was happening there.

“Who would have thought the eldest son of our dear baron had such talents? Flat stones? A heated flooring system? I heard you saved some money by making some weird things and talking the villagers into buying them.”

The news had shocked him at first.

“Thanks to that though,” Meatloaf went on, “some things cleared up for us at last. The baron has been faithfully paying his interests in recent days, and now, I know where he got the money. It came from selling the heated flooring system or something like that.”

“And with the money left, he paved the road and dug a mine. Smart. Really, kekeke.” Scrawny Shiloh snickered.

He couldn’t help it. *A coal mine? And a new one even?* His senses were tingling, and they were excellent at spotting money-making opportunities. If he got his hands on that mine, it would surely be a golden goose for a while for both of them.

“As such, that’s why we are here. To visit the dear baron and have a nice, very nice conversation.”

“What do you mean by a very nice conversation?”

“Let’s say we’re striking a deal that is mutually beneficial.”

Shiloh greasily smiled at Lloyd’s inquiry, and then, he turned to the baron. He gave an arrogant look to the baron.

“Why don’t you tell your son directly?” Shiloh demanded.

The baron stayed silent.

Shiloh clicked his tongue. Lifting his sharp and bony cheek high, he said, “If you have no plans on telling him, I will do it. Simply put, the baron will hand over the rights of the mine to us, and we will exempt him from three months of interest. But you see, the baron has been turning down our offer for some reason.”

“What does the young gentleman have to think about it? It doesn’t seem like a bad idea for you to directly persuade your father. This offer we’re making…don’t you think it’s superb?”

Superb, my ass. I worked my butt off day and night to construct the mine, and they're exempting what? Just three months of interest? Lloyd was at a loss of words. It was too ridiculous. He clenched his fists unwittingly and gritted his teeth. He neither lifted his fists nor scowled.

He knew he would be giving them the upper hand in the negotiation if he let them know that they angered him. *The angrier I am, the more relaxed I should become. The more annoyed I am, the slier I should act.*

"Oh, my! The deal you're suggesting sounds like a win-win to me."

"Right?!"

Right, my foot. Let me show you how I'll turn things around so that the only winner here is me. Making such a decision in his head, Lloyd grinned.

"So I am going to make a suggestion as well. Will you hear me out?"

"Are you negotiating? I don't think there's a reason I should listen," one of them grunted.

"From now on, we will be repaying our debts in parts. Partial repayment of some sort. And any future interests will be lowered according to the principal that will be reduced as we keep repaying."

"What...?"

"Oops, did you say you didn't need to hear it? But I suppose you did already."

A look of distaste played across Shiloh and Meatloaf's faces. Stroking his plump chin, Meatloaf said, "I don't think I can agree to that."

"I agree. That'll be difficult. We don't do partial repayments. It's our policy," Shiloh seconded.

He then went on, "If you're going to pay, it must be in full. Paying in parts just won't work. That's not how we do things."

“Ha. Do you mean that we should pay that hefty principal all at once?”

“Of course.”

“Then do you mean that we should keep paying the exorbitant interest all the while?” Lloyd asked.

“That’s how we do business. Didn’t you borrow money from us, knowing all that?”

Shiloh raised his eyebrows, throwing a confused look at Lloyd. What Shiloh said was actually reasonable. After all, they were loan sharks. Their goal and business methods were to lend the least amount of money and make more of it through exorbitant interests. So, there could never be such a thing as partial payment for them. The principal did nothing but increase.

How many in this world would be able to pay off the exorbitant amount of money all at once? That would be impossible, especially for those who reached out to these loan sharks to get some quick money. This means that those who borrowed money from them would be ensnared in the trap of unpayable debt. Like ants trapped in the ant lion’s pit, no one would be able to get out no matter how they struggle.

They would be sapped of all body fluids and end up as empty shells. *And when the debtor can’t hold up any longer and files for bankruptcy or dies, they purchase their real estate and whatnot to sell at a high price.* This was the two loan sharks’ favorite business tactic. In addition, it was the same trap Baron Frontera fell for. Lloyd decided to put a stop to this scam. *If I don’t end this now, they’ll never leave me alone no matter how much money I make.* The repayment should be accepted in parts and the interest rate should be adjusted according to the decreasing principal. Many things would change once he could get these two to agree to his demands. It wouldn’t be a private loan anymore and it’d be similar to a normal loan. Repaying them would become much easier.

“So that’s why I’m making a deal here. How does that sound? This offer I’m making—don’t you think it’s superb?”

It didn’t matter to Lloyd whether they scoffed or not. He put on a brazen expression and pushed forward. Of course, Shiloh and Meatloaf’s snickers grew louder. Shiloh didn’t even care to hide the mockery in his smile.

“It looks like this young gentleman has lost his mind today. What strange requests you keep griping about! Did you really think that we would accept this outrageous deal of yours?”

“Of course, I do,” Lloyd said.

“Of course?”

“Yes,” Lloyd confirmed.

“Why is that?”

“Because I brought a friend who’s excellent at negotiations.”

“What...?”

Shiloh cocked his head to the side. Meatloaf frowned, the wrinkles on his forehead visible and deep.Lloyd turned around and toward the door, he said, “Hey, you can come in now.”

It was the moment Lloyd spoke out. Just then…*Slam! Fwoosh!* The door of the reception room opened with such force that even Lloyd wondered if it would be snapped in its entirety.

It created a gust of wind so strong that the collar of Lloyd’s shirts and two loan sharks’ hair swayed in the air.

Then someone bellowed in a loud, crying noise.

“Nice to meet you! I, Orc Arosh, on behalf of the Sand and Steel Tribe, have come to meet the master of the Frontera barony, oink!”

Whoosh! His piercing shout echoed through the room.

Shiloh and Meatloaf unwittingly covered their ears with their hands.

Frightened to the bone, they buried themselves in the chairs. The baron was just as frightened as them.

“Hey, uhm...Long time no see?”

“Yes, oink!”

“Have you come here with my son, Lloyd?”

“Of course! I have come to send the will of my chief, oink!”

“His will?” The baron asked.

“This, oink!”

Stomp, stomp, stomp! Arosh strode across the reception room with his buff muscles.

He tightened his pecs when he passed the frightened loan sharks and placed something heavy on the table. It was a fang of a giant monster.

“It’s the fang of Kargas, which can be hunted by only the bravest and most courageous warrior. The chief wanted you to have it as a seal, oink.”

“A seal? What seal?”

“A seal of blood alliance, oink.”

“What?” The baron’s eyes widened in surprise.

And Arosh continued to explain. “The whole tribe is indebted to Lloyd Frontera. Not only that, he is one of the historically few humans who are acknowledged as the warrior by us the orcs, oink.”

“What...” The baron’s eyes became larger.

It was only natural. *Lloyd got acknowledged as a warrior by the orcs?* Lloyd had achieved what he boasted he would do before. It hadn’t been an

easy task at all. No, it was almost impossible. Of course, there were a few exceptions.

The most popular story was about an anonymous girl who was acknowledged by the great chief Akash hundreds of years ago. However, that was an event that happened in the distant past. It was also only recorded in history books, so its veracity could not be ascertained.

So, the baron barely expected that Lloyd would be able to get approved as a warrior by the orcs when he sent Lloyd away. A similarly unrealistic event was happening now, officially being announced by Arosh, the formidable orc warrior and the son of the chief.

“Moreover, you are the father of Lloyd Frontera, the lifesaver and warrior. You are fully worthy of forming a blood alliance with my tribe, oink.”

Arosh's voice was sincere, and his expression was solemn.

“How does that sound, Lord Frontera? Are you willing to take my chief’s will and form a blood alliance, oink?”

The baron swallowed. This was a great opportunity he never even dared to dream of.

Forming a blood alliance with the orc tribe… This meant that the Frontera barony would become an official member of the alliance of the orc tribes.

“Of course.”

This wasn’t something to hesitate over or sleep on. The baron nodded his head after making a decision. Arosh smiled in satisfaction, revealing his fangs.

“Good! From now on, the Frontera barony is a blood ally of my tribe! We are friends, brothers, and sisters, oink!” Arosh declared.

The baron and Arosh shook hands. While this was taking place, the two loan sharks merely remained in their seats and dazedly looked at the scene.

A little later, when Arosh looked at the two, they found themselves flinching and shuddering.

“But who are these people? Arosh heard everything outside the room. Those humans kept looking down on the baron, oink.”

Scrawny Shiloh and Fatty Meatloaf visibly trembled. The following question of Arosh made their hearts race faster.

“Tell me, are they your enemies, oink?”

The barony and the Sand Steel Tribe were allies by blood. The barony’s enemy was the tribe’s enemy. The virtue of a warrior was to immediately execute the enemies of the tribe and the orcs were famous for being sticklers for paying back a favor. Unfortunately, the two loan sharks knew quite well about the customs of those orcs.

“Hmm, I am not so sure. But they may, unfortunately, become one when they turn down my offer.” Lloyd smiled and teasingly commented.

When they heard Lloyd, cold sweat started to drip down the two loan sharks’ backs.

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Chapter 42: How to Solve a Food Shortage (1)

Scrawny Shiloh and Fatty Meatloaf made a run for their lives. They did so after acquiescing to Lloyd and taking up his offer. They had no choice. Orc Arosh was flaring his nose beside them. He glowered at them with eyes akin to an angry gorilla.

He was ready to immediately lift the table and slam their heads with it as soon as Lloyd declared them an enemy of the Frontera barony. There weren't many people who could remain calm next to an angry orc. The two loan sharks weren't an exception.

We might really die. The sweat glands in their backs opened up, and they started to sweat profusely, but their sense of trepidation and nervousness wasn't groundless. They knew very well that orc warriors cared little for human law.

If things go south, he might just kill us right away and run back to the wasteland. If that were to happen, they would die in the hands of the furious orc. They would be dying for nothing. After quickly assessing the situation in their heads, the two immediately flashed a smile usually reserved for potential customers.

"Eh? When did we say that we won't accept the young master's offer? Of course, we will take it. Yes, yes, of course, we should," Meatloaf spoke hurriedly.

Shiloh agreed without any hesitation. "Of course we will, considering our relationship. Do you have a contract? I can sign one right away."

"Is that so? My, I am filled with gratitude." A sly smile formed on Lloyd's face.

Lloyd handed the contract to the loan sharks. It was about two things. One was permitting the baron to pay the debt in part and another was reducing the amount of interest according to the remaining principal. The two loan sharks signed the contract, enduring the welling-up bitterness in their heart.

The two not only signed but also stamped it with a seal, but that was only under duress. Lloyd was silently pressuring them.

“Then...So long!”

As soon as they stamped the paper, Shiloh and Meatloaf bolted out of the house like a puppy that needed a potty break. Lloyd had struck a deal and he got what he wanted.

Very good. I was able to get the best result possible in my current situation.

The plan to threaten them with Arosh was very effective. Orc warriors were not restrained by human laws.

They were above the law in the most literal sense. The loan sharks loved to abuse the law and system. So there wasn’t anyone more perfect to counter them with than Arosh.

Of course, if I could just follow my whim, I’d have threatened them more severely to clear the entire debt. Lloyd couldn’t do that because it was impossible in the first place.

It’s illegal. Sure, they’re loan sharks, but it’s true that this barony legally owes them money.

If Lloyd pushed himself and completely nullified the debt by threatening them, the two loan sharks would report him right away.

He would probably be charged with financial blackmail. In short, the entire barony would be caught in a legal debacle. *I can’t let that happen.* However, the two terms he had gotten out of the loan sharks a while ago fell within the confines of the law. That was the farthest he could go. In other words, he had managed to extract the cream of the crop in this situation.

I’m satisfied for now. I’ll get nothing if I try to get everything. One step at a time, and the way out will appear. He still had a long way to go to pay the entire debt but he believed that he would be able to pay off every penny if

he kept working hard. Thinking that in his head, Lloyd turned to face the baron and Arosh.

“So, now that our barony and the Sand and Steel Tribe have become friends, let’s take a celebratory selfie...No, a painting, shall we?”

“That sounds like a good idea.” The baron nodded happily.

Arosh titled his head at the word ”celebratory painting.” Lloyd instructed the housekeeper to summon an artist. The Frontera barony was a remote province in the eastern region of the kingdom. The Sand and Steel Tribe, the powerful tribe over the eastern mountain range.

The two powers that were poles apart had formed a blood alliance. It was truly a historic moment.

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The following day. Lloyd began to busy himself without getting some rest to relieve his travel fatigue. *I don’t have any time to space out.* Time wasn’t on his side. Even now, time was flying by before he knew it. Each passing day meant a day closer to the payment deadline—he couldn’t waste any time. He had to work harder. Lloyd wrote down a list of things he needed to get done in order.

First, I want to take care of the treasures I received from the orcs in exchange for building the seokbinggo. The gold and silvers were long used as fitness tools so they were damaged in many ways. Still, disposing of them at once would amount to something quite considerable. Even if he considered the damages the treasures accumulated from poor treatment, they would cover about twenty percent of the debt.

Apart from the treasures, there was something else as well. The metal bars Bangul had occasionally excreted were stacked up quite high. A portion of them was for sales, while the rest was for future construction. *Add to that and the treasures, and I might be able to pay thirty percent of the principal. But there is no way to sell them right now.*

Even if he owned precious and expensive items, they meant nothing if no one wanted to buy them. The Frontera barony was occupied by ordinary farmers, woodcutters, and some small merchants who sojourned in the fiefdom. There was no one to purchase the treasures and metals.

Even so, I can't hand those over to the two loan sharks. They'll surely haggle the prices of these items way too low. So I must cash them out. The loan sharks had to be paid in coins.

Once he made up his mind, Lloyd resolved to travel to a big city soon to sell those treasures and metals in exchange for gold coins.

Of course, he would need to prepare first before going there. Should he travel all the way there with such a huge crate of items and sell nothing... Should he find no buyers… He would be wasting both time and effort. Every step he takes would be in vain, and so Lloyd went to the baron. He asked the baron to find a merchant who could buy the items he had brought here a few days ago.

"I see that it must be taken care of first. Yes. I will ask around for the merchant. Once I find a buyer, I will arrange it, so you can go to the City of Cremo with those items of yours."

Cremo was a central trade city in the Cremona region, and the Frontera barony sat in the middle of it. *Whew, so now, I just have to wait until everything is arranged for me to dispose of those items. In the meantime, I will deal with the others.* Another task of priority was excavating coal.

That's why I invited the orc miners. Lloyd lifted his head. The lot space in front of the mine.

one hundred twenty buff orc miners stood there. Lloyd shouted toward them, "Okay, so I believe you have already heard what kind of work we will be doing."

"We've heard, oink!"

"Dig, oink!"

“Break, oink!”

The orc miners lifted their large fists and flailed them around. Lloyd repressed his smile.

“Yes, you are right. We will go into the mine. After that, we will excavate the coal and split and break the rocks.”

“Breaking is fun, oink!”

“I am excited, oink!”

The orc warriors became even more excited. They lifted the pickaxes and shovels that were given to them to use. Their energy was so intense they looked like they were preparing for battle and perhaps that was why the orc warriors widened their already large eyes when they heard what Lloyd said next.

“But not everyone here will be working at the same time. Because, you see, every job has a proper order.”

“What, oink?”

“What do you mean, oink?”

They were curious and they cocked their heads to the side. Lloyd continued to explain.

“Everything that I do is for the sake of ensuring efficiency and safety. Now, look from there to there. And from here to there. Okay, good. Let’s divide into groups.”

Lloyd commanded the orc miners, motioning. After a small bustle, the orcs divided themselves into four groups, with thirty orcs in each.

“Good job. And now, please name your groups for easy identification.”

“Chest, oink!”

“Back, oink!”

“Shoulders, oink!”

“Legs, oink!”

The orc miners bawled the names. Just like that, the names of the four groups were decided in a clip.

Lloyd spoke, “Good job. And now, I will inform you of the schedule for each group.”

Deploying the orc miners by dividing them into groups...That was Lloyd’s plan.

Two shifts every day. One in the day. The other at night. They would be working for six days and on the seventh day...*Everyone will rest. After all, rest is crucial.* Then the following week, the night and day shifts would be switched. Those who pulled the day shift in the previous week would do the night shift and vice versa. Once such a plan was announced, a commotion broke out among the miners.

“Then we will go in there first, oink!”

“We will dig for coal all day, oink!”

“Workout! Workout, oink!”

The orcs just saw the mine work as exercise…And because of their passion, Lloyd had to sweat a lot to quell them down. It took him a lengthy explanation of how muscles grow faster when their scheduled workouts and breaks are balanced. Aside from this method, Lloyd supervised the men in other ways.

The mine work is tiring and dangerous. Each group was added with five civil engineer soldiers. He appointed them as safety guards. Moreover, a ventilation system was installed in the mine and anti-dust masks were provided. Working after hours was banned and Lloyd installed bath

facilities at the entrance of the mine. Not only that, he gave the orc miners a lodging where they could rest up and be at ease.

On top of that, there is also storage as well. He expanded the storage annexed to the estate.

The storage was for stockpiling the coal. Lloyd had to spend a whole month making a proper excavation system.

Meanwhile, the orc miners went all out and boasted their strengths with their entire hearts.

They impeccably satisfied the expectations Lloyd had for them. Truly, they were the best miners there were. The daily labor was nothing but helpful exercise for them. They were never tired and their hearts brimmed with zeal. They wielded pickaxes with impressive strength and they could even push the extremely weighty wheelbarrows. Thanks to them, the coal excavation took off lightning-fast. Wheelbarrows fully loaded with coal were wheeled out of the mine every hour and driven along the paved roads to be stacked up in the estate storage.

Each time it happened, Lloyd found himself growing more content. *Good. Very good.*

The bituminous coal would be translated to money when the winter came. The thought of it brought a satisfied smile all over his face and there was something else that pleased him.

Ding Dong.

[The heroic story about you is being spread throughout the fiefdom.]

[You have set an example to the others by boldly risking your life to save the soldiers kidnapped by the dark sorcerer.]

[The rescued civil engineer soldiers have been praising you nonstop to their families, relatives, and acquaintances all through the month.]

[Now, everyone in the fiefdom has heard about your feat.]

[Everyone in the fiefdom sends their praises to your noble valiance.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 300 RP.]

[Current RP: 911]

Great.

This was another achievement he hoped to obtain since he got back to the fiefdom and at last, his hope materialized when he earned three hundred RP. *RP is an asset I can save up and use whenever I need to.* It was an intangible asset and weapon that only he could access.

However, despite the flood of accomplishments, he didn't idle around and lose focus. There was still a long way to go and that long way wouldn't be a walk in the park. It would instead be rife with small and big obstacles throughout the way. So, the obstacles that he could predict in advance had to be cleared or prepared for.

"For instance, one of the potential problems would be the awe-inspiring appetite the orcs have."

"Appetite, Young Master?" Javier asked when Lloyd spoke to him that night.

Javier lifted his gaze to look at the young master. His question brought Lloyd to smile while sitting on the desk in the bedroom.

"It's just as I said. They have amazing appetites. They eat like a madman."

It was true. The orcs' appetites were incredible. If one of them were to debut as a mukbang streamer in South Korea, he would draw a massive audience.

"But if you think about it, it's pretty obvious. They are huge. Moreover, their huge body is mostly composed of muscles. Plus, they use a lot of energy from working half a day in the mine."

“Right. I was a bit surprised earlier by how much they eat.”

“Right? We’re holding up pretty well because we have stored a huge volume of food, but give it a year or two. We’ll run out of food, and all hell will break loose.”

That was true as well. Right now, Lloyd could feed them with the food that had been previously amassed, but one or two years later, the food storage would become empty.

“And that means we’d have to buy rice from the neighboring fiefdom at a high price. If we don’t have a plan, that is.”

“You sound like you have a plan in mind.”

“Do I?”

“Yes.”

“Ding! You are right.”

Lloyd smiled in satisfaction.

“My dear Javier, it looks like sticking around your wise, older friend is paying off. You’ve gotten smarter.”

“I was smart in the first place,” Javier rebutted.

“Oh, yeah?”

“Yes, and besides...”

Javier replied impassively.

“I am not your friend, Master Lloyd.”

“Oh, is that so?”

“Yes.”

“Don’t you sometimes have this growing impulse in your heart to call me ‘friend’?”

“I mean this in the most assured and certain way. I never, ever want to call you such.”

“You hate the idea that much?”

“Yes.”

“Hmm...I was going to teach you something extraordinary if you call me your ‘friend’ just once.”

“Are you curious what the secret is?” Lloyd allured.

“No, never,” Javier said flatly.

“Tsk, you are a brat.”

“Thank you, Young Master. Although I am a bit curious what solution you have in mind.”

“You mean the solution to solve the food shortage because of the orcs?”

“Yes.” Javier nodded.

This young master he served...Sometimes, the man flustered him. Right now was one of those times. *I can never make out what he is.* The young master spoke nonsense all day.

Even more, he was petty. There was also a side of him that was sly and evil. To be completely honest with his feelings, Javier slightly hated him and found him difficult. At times, Lloyd was unpredictable, enigmatic, and mysterious in the most extraordinary way.

The present conversation was one of those moments Javier felt that way about him. How he scoffs casually and explains the plan that Javier had never even fathomed in his head.

“It’s simple. I am going to turn the wasteland on the south side of the fiefdom into farmland. Well, if you’re asking how I will do it, I’m thinking of mixing the vertical drain (VD) technique.”

“How’s that?” Lloyd smiled at Javier, the latter feeling overwhelmed for some reason.

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Chapter 43: How to Solve a Food Shortage (2)

The Maritz Wetland was abandoned land. It was filled with muddy swamps, which were inhabited by unidentified living creatures. As such, erecting a building or doing farm work there was impossible. The land was useless and was good for nothing. The Maritz Wetland was treated as if it was nonexistent for generations. The Frontera barony was to its north and the Lacona viscounty was to its south. It was ignored by both lands, but nothing was surprising about that since everyone deemed it dead and barren in the first place.

But of course, those perceptions will all be a thing of the past. It will be different from now on.

Thinking that, Lloyd lifted his head. He turned around and carefully asked, “Are you alright?”

“Of course.” Baron Frontera, who was following behind Lloyd, nodded.

Lloyd quickly gave a full scan of the baron with his gaze. The baron was wearing knee-high boots. The pair was made out of oiled leather, so it boasted an almost perfect waterproof function. Unfortunately, however, today was the day the pair failed to do their job properly.

“It doesn’t look like you are alright. It looks like the water and mud have already gotten into your boots.”

The thing was, the water level in this swampy area went above their knees. So each time the two took a step, they sunk into the water up to their thighs. Thanks to that, the inside of the baron’s boots were already thoroughly soaked. Even his trousers were thoroughly ruined as well. Surprisingly, the baron turned out to be a man of tenacity.

“It’s alright. I expected this to happen.”

“Hmm, is that so?”

*I don’t think he actually did...*Lloyd looked back on what had happened two hours ago.

***

Two hours ago. Lloyd went to the baron’s office. He went there to discuss his plans to develop the Maritz Wetland that sat south of the barony. The reason and purpose behind the development were clear. It was to produce more food for the fiefdom. *I need to feed the orc miners. And if not for that, it’s always encouraging to expand the agricultural land of the fiefdom.*

Agriculture was the foundation of all industries. That was the case even for advanced societies. The basic issue of food had to be resolved before they could move forward.

Lloyd thought the same principle applied to the fiefdom.

Orc miners are just the start. One day, the population here will grow bigger. If we can’t produce food by then to meet the population level, we’ll be in trouble.

The number of mouths to feed would increase, so he needed to expand production accordingly but the fiefdom was out of land to farm on. The only possible option left was the Maritz Wetland, so Lloyd needed to drain the water there.

A reclamation construction was essential, but to do that, he needed the baron’s approval.

So he revealed the plan to the baron, coming prepared with a way to persuade him if he refused. Shocking him, the baron gave an unexpected answer.

“Do you then plan on observing the topography of the wetland?”

“Excuse me? Well, yes. That is my plan.”

“Okay. Then I am going with you.”

“Excuse me...?”

“Don’t take the servants. You and I can go, just the two of us. First, I should get changed into something more comfortable. Wait here a little.”

The baron immediately started to change his clothes without waiting for Lloyd to answer.

He put on something more comfortable to move in and a pair of leather rain boots.

He even tucked a small knife into his waist. What was more, he even ordered one of the servants to make a lunchbox!

“Hmm...I am not going on a picnic, you know,” Lloyd explained.

“I know.”

“Then, why bring a lunchbox...”

“Surely, it would be troublesome if we get hungry in the wetland.”

“I know that, but still...” persisted Lloyd.

“Am I wrong?”

Lloyd had to shut his mouth.

The baron wasn’t wrong about that but he was wrong to think of this as a picnic. *And he thinks it’s a happy one.* Lloyd couldn’t wrap his head around the baron’s actions.

He was heading to look around and survey the murky swamps in the wetland, but the baron got ready as though a picnic was waiting for him.

What is he so excited about? Even when he and the baron went out of the estate, cut across the fiefdom toward the south, and floundered around in the muddy swamps after getting there, the baron’s attitude still was a mystery to Lloyd. It was the case even at this moment.

“Whew! Wheeew!” The baron breathed heavily, panting.

Each step he took in the swamp turned him into a slapstick comedian. The reason was simple: The baron had raised his arms to save the lunchbox. Unable to just watch any longer, Lloyd said, “Uhm, can you give me that lunchbox basket? I will hold it for you.”

“No, I am fine.”

“But if you keep your hands raised like that, your arms will start to hurt, and balancing yourself will be more difficult.”

“It’s not hard. Focus on your work,” the baron insisted.

“Well, having that in my arms won’t affect what I’m doing, really.”

Lloyd was telling the truth. He had been using the surveying skill from earlier and didn’t have to focus to use it. *The data from the survey results is stored automatically.*

The data from the survey could be called upon anytime he wanted when he returned to the estate later. He could focus on it then and so, right now, holding a picnic basket for the baron was a cinch. The baron, however, was stubborn as a mule.

“I’m the one who told you that I would tag along. So how can I burden you?” the baron said.

“Hmm, you don’t have to think like that.”

“I am really fine, so do go on.” The baron motioned with his eyes.

“Yes,” said Lloyd. “Shall we then rest for a bit over there?”

Straight ahead, there was an elevated area in the middle of the wetland. It was a small mound whose soft patch of grass rose above the water. *Even so, it can only be a few feet wide at best.* It was the perfect place for a respite.

“Please follow me. Don’t trip yourself.”

“Do not worry. Whew!”

Lloyd led the baron to the mound. Once he was up, he noticed a considerably flat and wide rock. Lloyd sat on the rock and collected his breath. Meanwhile, the baron opened up the basket beside him. Inside was a wooden lunch box wrapped in pure white cloth.

“I’ve been wondering, what’s in there that makes you care for it so much?”

“Isn’t it obvious? I brought the most delicious food in the world.” The baron grinned as he opened up the box.

And inside, there were...

“I brought boiled eggs and tomatoes.”

“Eh?” Lloyd asked.

“The tomatoes are drizzled with lots of honey. Here, take a fork.”

Lloyd was a little surprised. Since he was a noble, he expected the lunch to be something fancier. The content smile on the baron’s face deepened.

“Are you dazed because it has been a while? But you see, this was your favorite food when you were young.”

“It is still clear in my eyes. You threw such a tantrum that you did not want all sorts of nice, greasy foods on the table. Instead, you insisted that boiled eggs and honey-soaked tomatoes were the best. How embarrassed I was each time you did that.”

Lloyd remained silent.

“Sometimes, even now, I regret it,” a look of remorse flashed on his face. “I should have given you as many boiled eggs and tomatoes as you wanted...”

Lloyd didn’t know what to say. He simply chewed on his lips with a fork in his hand.

The surveying skill had already been turned off. Lloyd simply stared at his fork, blank and wordless. The baron grinned and peeled an egg before handing it to his hand.

“Here, take the salt. Dip the egg in it. Make sure to drink some water, so you don’t choke.”

“You haven’t talked since earlier. Am I making you feel awkward?”

“Uh, Uhm, it’s not that,” Lloyd finally uttered.

“No, I completely understand.”

The baron’s gaze at Lloyd flashed inexplicable remorse.

It was short-lived as the baron burst out in laughter. “Hahaha. I am making you very uncomfortable. Here, let us eat now.”

“Yes...”

After that, neither the baron nor Lloyd spoke. They simply ate the crumbling boiled eggs and tomatoes as they sat on a rock in the grayish wetland. For the past few months, the baron regretted his past behaviors. Back then, he had been sorely disappointed with his son for not meeting his expectations. He had hated Lloyd. However, he felt sorry for his son at the same time. The baron wanted to apologize to Lloyd for his past behaviors.

But it wasn’t easy for him to work up the courage to express those regrets out loud. Instead, he silently passed the water bottle to Lloyd. Lloyd drank from it without saying a word, either. In return, Lloyd passed the salt to dip the eggs. The two continued to remain silent. On the way home, it was Lloyd who held the lunchbox basket. The baron didn’t refuse Lloyd this time. The basket was lighter on their way home. And albeit very slightly, their steps became lighter as well. Just like that, the first day of surveying the wetland passed by.

***

Even after the first survey, Lloyd preoccupied himself with surveying for quite a while.

The Maritz Wetland was more vast than he expected. A day or two of surveying wasn't enough to cover the entire land. *But I'm thankful that this is an intermediate-level skill.*

Because it was intermediate, he was able to survey about 130 feet of land in one try.

After doing everything he could with the skill, he succeeded in surveying quite a lot of land. About twenty days or so later Lloyd was done surveying most of the land that would be reclaimed in the first part of the construction. The topography of the land within the range was now in his hands. However, that didn't mean everything would be smooth sailing from now on. *Constructing is a matter entirely different from surveying.* Lloyd furrowed his brows as he studied the topographical data of the Maritz Wetland.

I expected there would be many variables but not this many. The wetland was situated on low-lying ground, embracing two courses of a river. There were frequent floods, and the stagnant river water invaded the land as there was no proper drainage system. And after a long period, the land turned into a wetland.

Seriously, anywhere you go, these stagnant waters are always a problem.

Whether it was about a game or a piece of land, it was the same. The stagnation had to be solved adequately to survive a game or sell a piece of land. Thinking of that fact in his head, Lloyd racked his brain to figure out a way to reclaim the wetland.

Of course, I have a plan. I just have to use the vertical drain technique with the support of my summon partners. Quicken the consolidation process, and I'm good to go. But I must make sure that the embankments and waterways are installed exactly where they should be. However, there were just too many variables because of the sheer size of the land mass.

Lloyd wasn’t sure whether the water would fully drain as he intended it to. *But I can’t hastily start the construction without any thought. That might backfire on me.* Lloyd would find himself in serious trouble if the water didn’t drain after having toiled away to make the embankments and waterways. All the work and money he put in would be in absolute vain.

That was the last thing he wanted to experience.

Hmm. I wish I could run a simulation at least. It would be nice if I could run a simulation by throwing the topographical data of the Maritz Wetland into a supercomputer. However, that was impossible in this world.

Just then…

“Uhm...”

In one corner of the bedroom, Javier fidgeted in a comfy chair. Lloyd wondered if Javier was having a bad dream. His elegant eyebrows were furrowed. *He’ll wake up if I just leave him like this,* Lloyd thought to himself. So, he recited a magical spell in Javier’s ears.

“The drain construction method consists of a draining tool to collect rainfall and river water that has penetrated the embankment during a flood, and a filtering tool to prevent the draining tool from clogging by receiving drainage at a fixed rate. The thickness of the drain ball...blah blah blah… At least 1.5 feet above the ground in the embankment… The average dynamic slope (H/D) on the front of the drain hole does not exceed 0.3…blah blah… A structure that ensures a constant safety rate against slip destruction… Go fall asleep, zap.”

Javier sunk back to sleep. Lloyd grinned. He grinned as an alternative method to create a simulation popped into his head while reciting a passage from his textbook to put Javier to sleep.

It’s a good thing that I read the chapter about embankment building. The answer was right there in the textbook. Okay, let’s try it out. He walked out of the bedroom and headed to the training hall, which is the backyard of his estate.

There, under the moonlight, he held up his shovel. He dug the soil, gathered it into one place, and carefully shaped it. Next, he fetched some water and mixed it with mashed grass and red clay. He then collected small pebbles around the area. The beads of sweat on his face glistened against the moonlight. Lloyd kept busying himself even after that until the following morning rolled around. The result of his toil revealed itself under the sun. It was a miniature model of the Maritz Wetland that was about thirteen feet in width and length.

“Whew. I wonder if this will do.”

Lloyd grinned in contentment as exhaustion washed over him. In his eyes, the miniature model of the wetland looked quite convincing. *Of course, it should. The model is based on the data I collected with my surveying skills.*

He had reflected countless details of the wetland in the model, including the overall topography, height, slope, amount of stagnated water, and water flow. With such a precise model, he would be able to try out a simulation in a more traditional way.

Let’s get started. Lloyd rolled his sleeves and pants all the way up. He started touching the model like a farmer planting new crops. A miniaturized embankment was created into the model as he used his design skills. He bore a hole in the ground and a waterway in the other.

Afterward, he studied how the water was drained. The job wasn’t easy.

Now, once the morning gave way to the afternoon, the scorching summer sun beat down on Lloyd mercilessly. It beat down on his back. No, it was grilling him, to be more exact. His back began to sweat profusely as if he was soaked with rain. The sight brought a crowd of villagers around him.

“Look, what is Master Lloyd up to now?”

“Maybe he realized how fun it is to play in the mud.”

“That’s not it. It must be for something else, I’m sure.”

Perhaps it was a relief that people no longer unilaterally doubted him like before. Things have changed. Lloyd went on running an analog simulation under the gaze of countless observers but he failed each time he tried. The water was drained, sure, but not enough to satisfy Lloyd. However, he didn't give up. He would never back down until he found the way.

If I were going to back down and give up, I wouldn't have started it in the first place! Each failure stimulated him to be more tenacious.

He yelled, "Again!" and restored the model with his hands, poured the thick water once more, and created embankments and waterways of various shapes. After a series of attempts and failures, when it was late in the afternoon, and the sun was slowly setting down...

At last, Lloyd invented an embankment and waterway model that properly drained the water. *I did it!* Lloyd clenched his fists, his body soaked in fatigue and sweat. The water was finally draining out properly. Furthermore, the shapes of the embankment and waterway were preserved without being destroyed. Lloyd reaped the sweet reward of an entire day's worth of work. Just then, an unexpected message popped in front of him.

Ding Dong.

[You have overcome a limitation by being wise and tenacious amid hardship.]

[That special experience is having a strong effect on your <Skill: Design>]

[A new skill option has been opened.]

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Chapter 44: The Third Random Summon Game (1)

Ding Dong.

[A new skill option has been opened.]

[Skill Option 3: Simulation Mode - You can run a virtual simulation of the topographical data you have obtained from your surveying skill. This will allow you to observe various physical changes that occur within the terrain.]

Huh? Lloyd blinked several times. Did he blink because the beads of sweat streaked down his forehead and went into his eyes? No, it was because of the message that popped up in front of him. He couldn't believe what he read.

Wow. What is this? An optional enhancement for my design skill?

The skill was none other than simulation, the very skill he had direly wanted to have.

This was a reward he never thought nor expected to earn. However, Lloyd didn't remain dazed and quickly jumped into action. From the survey and design skills to the Asrahan Core Technique, he had thoroughly experienced the power of these optional skills. It was the same case here.

Actions speak louder than words.

He could read a manual for a hundred days or watch a tutorial over and over again for an entire day. The best way to master a game was to play right away and learn while getting cursed out by other players. So, Lloyd activated his design skill at once.

Crackle...!

A virtual hologram appeared in front of him. It was only visible to Lloyd and no one else. Lloyd imported the data from the survey of the Maritz

Wetland into it.

The terrain of the Maritz Wetland appeared in the virtual design space. This process was the same as all the other surveys and designs he had done prior except for that there was now a selection window at the bottom of the virtual space.

[Simulation Mode On]

This is the one. Lloyd knew immediately what it would do and he pressed the window.

[Skill Option Three: Simulation mode has been activated.]

[The topographical data of the current virtual design will be available for simulation.]

Bzzt! The background of the space brightened and numerous lines and dots appeared on the Maritz Wetland's terrain. It looked like a 3D graphic model. *I wonder if I can operate it similarly.* He wondered if that would be the case and so he held out his hand and pinched the line that had formed a mound. He then pulled it up.

Crash...! The peak of the mound pulled upward, following Lloyd's fingers.

Now, the small mound turned into a high hill that sat in the corner of the Maritz Wetland.

The murky mud and water that once surrounded the area consequently streamed down to the lower ground.*Wow.*He felt like he had become a god and that he was using a terrain editor in a simulation game.

This is awesome. Lloyd swallowed unwittingly. He was a civil engineering student and civil engineering involved more than only constructing buildings. *No, putting up buildings and structures is what architectural engineers do. Civil engineers do much, much more than just put up buildings.* There was a quote from a famous movie that said the wind was something to overcome not prepare for. Lloyd thought civil engineering

approached topographic evaluations in the same way. *Well, it's not completely similar. Topography is to be overcome and prepared for.*

That is, the goal of civil engineering was to plan and alter various terrains to enrich human lives. It drilled through mountains to create tunnels. It repaired jagged coastlines and then built ports. It studied and overcame numerous terrains to build roads and railways. It designed sewer systems and reclaimed lands or split them at times. It built bridges on top of steep cliffs, allowing people to connect with one another. Since the beginning of humanity, the very area of study that exercised the most influence on humankind was civil engineering. That was what Lloyd believed.

Therefore, meticulously studying and testing the terrain was necessary to accomplish such a goal. *And now, I have that weapon in my hands. Me, I have it.* He clenched his fists. It was after that Lloyd destroyed the miniature version of the wetland he had installed at the back of his yard.

He then zoomed off to take a bath and scraped the mud off his body. For five straight days, he then isolated himself from the world by shutting himself in his bedroom. Embankments and waterways were added and erased on the virtual Maritz Wetland. He added them again and he erased them once more. This took place over and over again. He ran the simulation as many times as he could. He meticulously went over the wetland development plan and reviewed it on repeat. Thanks to this skill, Lloyd was able to touch up the construction model he had completed in his backyard. Now, it was more sophisticated. While all of this was happening, Javier was forced to stay at Lloyd's side and serve him.

"Master Lloyd, it is time for your lunch."

"Mhm. Just leave it there."

"I think it is best to eat now."

"Now? But I'm busy. Can you not talk to me?"

"But you didn't even finish the breakfast I served you."

“Hey. Are you nagging me right now?”

“I am only speaking out of concern.”

“Concern? You? About me?”

“Yes.”

“No way. You’re worried about me? Look here. Who are you? Where did you hide my dear Javier?”

“It’s a joke. Can’t you see that I’m trying to focus right now?”

“Yes.”

“My serious expression and eyes. Can’t you see them?”

“No, I cannot. But...”

Javier sighed at length.

“I want to tell you that you have been fumbling your hands in front of nothing all day like someone has lost their mind.”

“Oh, given your subtle insults, you are indeed Javier. But, too bad for you, I have not gone mad.” Lloyd nonchalantly replied as he floundered his hands in the air.

Lloyd understood where Javier was coming from. *After all, this simulation space is visible only in my eyes.* Even now, Lloyd was delicately controlling the landform of the wetland he projected on the simulation space. He was testing out various ways to employ the vertical drain technique. Of course, this wouldn’t be visible to Javier’s eyes and to him, Lloyd would simply be making weird motions in the air.

“I am just thinking here. Haven’t you heard? How people’s senses are concentrated in their hands.”

“So?”

“So moving your hands like this stimulates your senses and triggers brain activity. Anyway, I seriously need to focus.”

“But, Master Lloyd, you must not skip your meals.” Javier stared at Lloyd.

“Oh, come on. You are not my mother.”

“If this goes on, I shall have to tell the baroness that you are not eating at all.”

“Tsk, I can’t,” Lloyd huffed.

“Excuse me?”

“I said I can’t think because of all your blabbering, you goody-two-shoes. Fine. Will you come over here then and take a seat on this comfy chair for a second?”

“What are you trying to do?” Javier asked, his voice sounding incredulous.

“If you sit down quietly, I will eat my lunch.”

“Do you really mean it?”

“Do you really think I’m trying to trick you?”

“I will sit...” Javier took his seat.

A mischievous smile formed on Lloyd’s face.

“Yes, good. Just take a break for a while. In principle, the Pack Drain (PD) method is the same as the Sand Drain or Paper Drain method...Four or six 12 cm diameter casings attached to a dedicated punching machine are simultaneously pressed into the ground...The installation depth can be up to 35m, and the installation diameter is 12 cm, making it workable...Blah blah...”

“Eh...? What are...”

*Snore.*An ambush lullaby service. He gave a passionate reading, recalling the words of the civil engineering textbook. Javier started to look absentminded, and his eyes soon lost focus.

He then started to doze off, his body slowly leaning to the side. Lloyd gently reached out and supported Javier's leaning body, nudging it toward the back of the chair. The forceful lullaby service went on so that Javier would completely knock out.

"The type of plastic board drain, PBD, can be divided into two. The first is a nonwoven drainage material, and a needle punch nonwoven plate with a thickness of about 5 mm is about 100 mm wide...There you go. Go fall asleep, boop."

Snore…

Javier fell into a deep sleep and now that Lloyd had created a suitable environment for work, he went back to concentrate on the simulation mode. One day, two days, and three days passed. Javier's nagging and the lullaby defense became a daily occurrence. However, the reclamation project for the Maritz Wetland started to shape up.

"I'm done."

On the fifth day, the corners of Lloyd's lips rose in satisfaction. Now, it was time to put together a team for the project and get his hands on the heavy equipment.

* * *

"Hey, Ppodong? Bangul?"

"Ppodong!"

"Bangul!"

The moon shone brightly that night and Lloyd was out in his backyard. Of course, Lloyd made sure that Javier was deep asleep.

“I’m thinking of summoning a new friend.”

“Ppodong?”

“Bangul?”

“I just think that it’d be better if you two came and watched me.”

Lloyd grinned. Tonight, he planned on picking a new summon partner. It was for the reclamation project that was expected to start soon.

“I hope something connected to water comes out. But I don’t mind even if that isn’t the case. I just need one that’s as large as you both.”

The Maritz Wetland reclamation project. The vertical drain method would be employed for the project. In short, it referred to drilling several holes in the floor of the wetland and inserting plastic drain boards to solidify the weak foundation. *The survey showed me that the wetland resembled the Netherlands terrain before it was reclaimed.* The low-level ground had stagnated with mud and muddy water for a long time. The thick peat deposit was full of water. Not only that, it was mushy and easily sunk in. But, what if Lloyd successfully drained the water there? *Things become easier.* Once water was sucked out of the peat deposit, it became compressed downward because of its weight. This phenomenon was called consolidation.

So it’s crucial to drain the water first. But I don’t have any equipment for VD. Not even a pump to suck out water. However, there were, of course, replacements he could use.

Javier could use his mana blast to bore holes in the ground and the summon partners could scoop the water out of the wetland. That’s why Lloyd was standing alone at night with Ppodong and Bangul: To pick another summon partner.

“Hey, Ppodong? Bangul?”

“Ppodong!”

“Bangul!”

“I wish the new guy could scoop water just as good as you all can,” Lloyd spoke, meaning every word.

Ppodong and Bangul were excellent at scooping water. Ppodong used his giant cheeks to hold huge amounts, and Bangul used her bloating stomach as a bucket. They could easily hold and transfer as much water as common water tanks. This was essentially possible because of the gigantic size these two grew when they ate the red sunflower seed. *Other summon partners should be similar. I just need to have four or five summon partners that can grow as large as Ppodong or Bangul. Nothing more.* Each summon partner held varying special powers and abilities and most of them became massive when they changed shape.

Lloyd planned on taking good advantage of their sheer size.

I don’t give a hoot about what its special power is. It’ll be icing on the cake if it’s connected to water, but I won’t push my luck. I simply need a big one! One that can transport water, whether that’s with its mouth or another body part. He had low expectations. *I was very lucky until now.* Ppodong and Bangul helped Lloyd by providing him with the most critical skills at the time. However, it would be for the better not to hope to strike such luck again, Lloyd thought to himself. With that thought, Lloyd opened the random summon window.

Ding Dong.

[Random Summon Game]

[Spend RP to pick a summon.]

[A strong and unique summon partner will provide their unwavering loyalty along with a wide range of skills to their master.]

[Cost of 3rd Random Summon Game = 100 RP]

*Hmm...*The cost of picking a new summon partner was increased by 1.5 times.

But it's all right. I've been frugal with my RP, and I have saved up. Lloyd checked how much RP he had. He had a whopping amount of 931, 20 of which were garnered from the recent trip (or picnic) to the wetland with the baron.

I have enough RP. Sometimes, a rush of impulse shot through him whenever he earned RP, and he thought about spending it rashly. However, he kept a tight rein, reminding himself that RP was his last resort in case of emergencies. Now, he was glad that he fought that impulse. *The goal is to pick four summon partners that are the size of Ppodong and Bangul and can carry water.*

If each pick cost 1.5 more RP than the previous pick, Lloyd calculated that he would need about 800 RP.

Let's give it a try. Determined, Lloyd gazed downward.

[Would you like to start the random summon game?]

[Yes / No]

Without a second of hesitation, he selected Yes.

[The random summon game is starting.]

Fwoosh! A magic circle appeared in the air and a pale light enveloped his whole surrounding.

The space rumbled, summoning a silhouette Lloyd could not recognize right away. The first thing he saw was a round-shaped body. Then, its head appeared next. It had round buttocks and legs and its overall silhouette was round like a ball. *Wait, it's not going to be the same kind as Ppodong, is it?* Lloyd focused his gaze and observed his newly summoned partner.

At last, the third summon partner revealed itself, a shock wave shooting out with it.

Crackle!

“Hamang!” Something shouted cutely.

It flew toward Lloyd’s side and landed in his arms. Lloyd accepted the new summon partner with both of his hands. He felt the plushy and soft texture of the skin on his palms and immediately checked his new friend. Lloyd’s eyes widened. He unconsciously murmured, “Wait...a thirsty hippo? What is he doing here?”

“Hamang!”

A small, chubby, and baby pink hippopotamus, whose name was “Hamang,” smiled brightly as he looked up at Lloyd from his palm.

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Chapter 45: The Third Random Summon Game (2)

“Hamang!”

“Eh...?”

Lloyd opened his eyes wide, his palm feeling the animal wriggling his small, chubby butt.

His head was round and he was gazing up at Lloyd with his beady eyes.

“Thirsty hippo?”

“Hamang!”

“Are you really a hippo?”

“Hamamang!”

The baby pink hippo nodded cutely as he stood on Lloyd’s palm. Was he happy because Lloyd brought him into this world? The baby hippo was joyfully smiling and he looked pretty cute.

But of course, I should never judge summon partners by their outside looks. Their cuteness was nothing but a first impression. Their real form was revealed when they ate the red sunflower seed. That was when they showed their true value and power. Buoyed with expectations, Lloyd asked the baby hippo, “Yes, nice to meet you. So your name is Hamang, right?”

“Hamamang? Hamang?”

“How did I find that out? Am I a genius?”

“Hamang!”

“No, I’m not a genius. I’m just an ordinary person.”

“Hamamang! Hamang!”

“I mean it. I just assumed based on your cry. Anyway, it’s nice to meet you, Hamang.”

“Hamang!”

New summon partners were always welcome. The senior summons, who were watching beside Hamang, welcomed him with all their hearts.

“Ppodong!”

“Bangul!”

“Hamang!”

With that, the introduction was finished. Seeing it was over, Lloyd asked, “Hamang? Do you carry a manual as well?”

“Hamang? Hamamang!”

“Can you please show it to me?”

“Hamang!”

Hamang opened his mouth. Just like Lloyd expected, he found a badly crumpled note inside.

He took it and carefully opened it up.

[Hamang User Manual]

[Hamang is a lovely baby hippopotamus. Please show him love and care.]

[Hamang will give his utmost loyalty to you, his master. A summon partner is not only your companion animal but also your family, so please don’t neglect them.]

[Unlike the other summon partners, Hamang does not eat sunflower seeds.]

[Unlike the other summon partners, Hamang cannot grow gigantic in size.]

[Hamang’s Skill Log]

[One Shot (Lv. 1)]

Eh? Lloyd cocked his head to the side. *One shot? He only has one skill?* Lloyd was slightly confused and doubtful at the same time.

He doesn’t eat sunflower seeds and cannot turn gigantic? Lloyd had a feeling that this new summon partner was different from Ppodong and Bangul in quite a lot of ways.

His gut told him something was off and ominous.

Forcibly suppressing the growing feeling that he was out of luck this time, Lloyd asked Hamang, “Hey, Hamang.”

“Hamang?”

“I am sorry to ask you this question, but do you, uhm, dislike sunflower seeds?”

“Hamamang? Hamang!”

Hamang nodded zealously.

“Hamang! Hamamang! Hamang!”

“You hate it that much...?”

“Hamang!”

He was adamant. So Lloyd hurriedly asked a follow-up question. “So, you don’t go boom and turn giant like your older brother Ppodong or older sister Bangul here?”

“Hamang!”

“You don’t need to?”

“Hamamang!”

“Because being cute is all that matters?”

“Hamang!”

Oh, crap. I’m screwed.

From the looks of it, Hamang’s only ability was to look cute and nothing more. Lloyd was slightly displeased. *Tsk, right. I’ve been pretty lucky up until now.*

As Lloyd came to think of it again, this was a “random” summon game. No one knew what kind of a summon partner would burst out of the magic circle. Sometimes you hit the jackpot and sometimes you didn’t. But which one had he been hitting so far?

*I’ve been lucky with Ppodong and Bangul. I obtained the skills that I needed the most. How I wish it was the same case this time. Hmm...*No, he had only hoped for a summoned partner who could turn enormous. It would’ve been fine even if they didn’t have a special power.

Lloyd’s plan involved mobilizing huge summon partners to drain the water in the wetland. *Out of all the summon partners out there, the one that can’t get big had to come out. A failure,* he thought to himself as disappointment filled his heart. However, he didn’t show it as he had brought this creature into this world. The responsibility to take good care of Hamang was on Lloyd.

Even though he may not be useful right now, that might change in the future.

Lloyd might find another way to use him in the future or Hamang could grow up. The situation could change at any time. Thinking that in his head, Lloyd warmly embraced Hamang.

“Then Hamang. Will you come in here?”

“Hamamang?”

“Come in with Ppodong. There you go. Good.”

“Hamang!”

Lloyd nested Hamang in his embrace.

And he checked his remaining RP.

[Current RP: 831]

Good. I still have enough. He had saved a lot of RP. He still owned over 800 RP after playing the random summon game. This would grant him three or four more attempts. Lloyd opened the summon game window.

[Random Summon Game]

[Cost of 4th Random Summon Game = 150 RP]

Surely, it got more expensive. However, he had no choice but to play it. Determined, Lloyd activated the game.

[Would you like to start the random summon game?]

[Yes / No]

He chose “Yes.” Just then…

Zzt! A spark crackled in the air, softly electrocuting his finger that pressed the “Yes” button.

“Ow.” He instantly pulled back at the sting.

Then, an unexpected message popped in front of him.

[The Random Summon Game can only be played once a day.]

[You can play the game after 23hr 47m 16s]

Oh, my. I didn't know there was a limit to this game. The corners of his lips twitched at the unexpected turn of events. *Tsk. I guess it's a total flop today.* He had intended to pick four summon partners in a row and start reclaiming the Maritz Wetland the first thing tomorrow.

But now, he was forced to alter his plans. *Great. The new summon partner is useless, and I can't pick anything more today. I can say goodbye to tomorrow's construction. How great would it be,* Lloyd wished, *if Hamang could turn gigantic?*

The more he wished for it, the more wistful he had become. However, there was nothing he could do about it. *Well, this isn't anything new if I think about the days I worked on construction sites.* Lloyd recalled his difficult life in South Korea. In need of quick cash, he had frequently worked on construction sites as they paid daily wages.

At first, young Lloyd was lofty. *I thought I'd make a lot of money if I worked a whole month without missing a single day.* He really thought it was possible. He was fairly confident that he could endure the hard, restless labor. He had plenty of motivation, but reality turned out to be a bit different.

I couldn't work every day as I'd wanted. It was outside of my control.

Many construction sites closed when it rained. That wasn't the end of it. Sometimes there was no work for him at all. When he was just starting out, there were times when he had to come back home even though he had gone to the employment agency at dawn. Things didn't get better for him even after he started getting recognized after frequenting the construction sites so often. It was the same even after he gained a regular team. When his senior couldn't get to work, it was a rest day for Lloyd, too, whether he liked it or not. That was the case since he was nothing but an assistant for his senior.

And so, I had to rest quite a lot of days. Working throughout the month and getting paid a heavy sum...? It turned out to be my lofty fantasy.

However, he couldn't remain disappointed with the harsh reality. Productively using his rest days was also important. What would happen if

he goofed around in boredom because he had no work? His hard-earned money from the previous day would be spent. If he worked one day, then took a break and spent what he earned the next day Lloyd would have ended up living paycheck to paycheck forever. He had seen quite a lot of people living like that at construction sites. *So I engrossed myself in my studies during those days. I did it even when I filed for LOA to earn money.*

Getting a permanent job was his dream, and he dreamed of his life turning for the better.

Truly, the days he had to live paycheck to paycheck in South Korea were difficult. *Compared to that, my current predicament is a walk in the park.* Just because things didn't go according to his plans and wishes, there was no reason he should let disappointment flood his heart.

If he was stumped, he should simply find what he could do right now. For instance, that would be checking out the one skill Hamang thankfully possessed. Resolved to do that, he looked down inside his arms.

"Hamang?"

"Hamaang?"

Could it be that he was drifting off in Lloyd's warm embrace? Hamang looked up, his black eyes slightly drowsy. A pleasant smile formed on Lloyd's face.

"Hamang, can I ask something about your skill?"

"Hamang?"

"The skill you have. One shot?"

"Hamang."

"What does it do?"

"Hamamang? Hamang! Hamang!"

“Drinking water?”

“Hamang!” Hamang nodded zealously.

Lloyd asked, “Uhm, I can drink water, too. Do you like drinking water?”

“Hamang!”

“How much do you like it?”

“Hamamang! Hamang!”

“Very very much?”

“Hamang!” Hamang nodded once again.

Gazing up, Hamang waved his short arms. “Hamamang. Hamang! Hamang! Hamamang?”

“Hmm... You mean you can drink as much as your stretched arms?”

“Hamang!”

A smile formed on Lloyd’s face again. *I guess I shouldn’t expect too much.* Hamang was barely the size of Lloyd’s fist. This hippo could stretch out his arms wide, but it was only a hand span long. That’s how much Hamang could drink. This meant that even if he drank to his heart’s content, it’d be just enough to fill up a small water balloon.

No, you never know. Lloyd shook his head. He decided not to form hasty judgments. He needed to see it with his own eyes. *Who knows? He might inflate himself, maybe, around the size of a gym ball. Or a bit larger than that.* If he did, that would be enough. Thinking so, Lloyd started to walk, heading out of the dark training hall that sat in his backyard.

“So Hamang.”

“Hamang?”

“I know a place with a lot of water. Do you want to go drink water with me?”

“Hamang!”

Hamang nodded several times as though the suggestion excited him. Lloyd patted and stroked his summon partner and walked out of the estate. He cut across the fiefdom under the moonlight. Then, to a place with lots of water, he went. He headed south and finally, he arrived at the northern boundary of the Maritz Wetland.

Buzzz!

As soon as he set foot in the wetland, he was fervently welcomed by a swarm of mosquitoes.

Lloyd waved his hands, repelling away the hungry pests. He resolved to himself, *Whew. I need to reclaim this wetland very soon.*

Mosquitoes were the source of all evil. Reminding this universal, unchanging truth to himself, Lloyd reached his hand into his embrace. He gently brought out Hamang, who was peacefully sleeping.

“So, Hamang.”

“Hamaang?”

“I am sorry for waking you up. So, you told me you like drinking water, right?”

“Hamang!”

The word “water” got Hamang to snap his eyes open. They started to glimmer.

Lloyd smiled.

“I am glad that you like it. That’s why we came here. Look ahead to see what’s in front of you.”

“Hamang?”

Hamang turned his round head and in front of him spanned the outstretched view of the wetland.

“Hamaaang?”

Hamang gaped slightly. There was rapture in his eyes. They resembled the eyes of a man who arrived at a buffet after starving for four days. Smiling, Lloyd gently pushed Hamang’s fat butt.

“I am glad that you like it. I took you here because I wanted you to drink to your heart’s content.”

“Hamang! Hamamang?”

“Are you asking if you could empty this place?”

“Hamang!”

“Yes, of course.”

“Hamamang!”

Hamang leaped to his feet in excitement.

Lloyd’s bitter smile deepened. *How I wish he could really drink all the water.* Lloyd told himself that he must not expect too much from Hamang. Looking at his small size, that task would be impossible. Realistically, a bucket load of water would be his limit. While such thoughts were crossing Lloyd’s mind, Hamang was getting ready to drink water.

“Hamamang! Hamang!”

He lifted his butt and lowered his head. He brought his mouth to the splashing water. The water drinking began, and it happened with unimaginable force.

Swooosh!

“Eh...?”

The water level lowered in a blink of an eye. The water that splashed some inches away from Lloyd’s feet became farther in no time and Hamang was growing gigantic at the same time!

“Hamang! Hamamang! Hamang!”

Hamang became six, nine, and then fifteen-foot tall. He continued to inflate like a balloon.

The larger he became, the lower the water level became. It was getting farther from Lloyd.

Hamang, despite his growing size, didn’t stop. He simply shoved his face deeper as the land started to run out of water.

“Hamamang!”

Swooosh! The water in the area was disappearing in real-time. No, it wasn’t disappearing. It was getting absorbed by Hamang. In no time, the bottom of the water in one area revealed itself and that’s when Hamang lifted his head. He was smiling in satisfaction as he lifted his now gigantic head.

“Hamang! Belch!”

Lloyd looked up at Hamang, feeling awed and terrified at the same time. However, first, he had to retreat several steps in a hurry to make sure that he wouldn’t get crushed under Hamang. Hamang reminded Lloyd of a ginormous water balloon whose diameter was over 150 feet. That was his first impression of Hamang as he looked up.

“Uhm, Hamang.”

“Hamaang?”

“Are you okay?”

“Hamang! Hamamang!”

“Your stomach doesn’t hurt or anything?”

“Hamang!”

I guess he really is fine. Embarrassed, Lloyd turned to look at the wetland, no, at the land that was once a wetland. The splashing water was completely gone. Some minnows and tadpoles and other creatures fluttered on the ground. However, of course, the entire wetland hadn’t been drained. The Maritz Wetland was a vast place. The area Hamang had drunken up was only a part of the vast wetland. Even so, it was enough. He did finish one area in one shot, leaving not a drop of water behind.

My goodness! I’ve hit the jackpot! He thought he failed this time, but once all the cards were revealed, he realized he had hit the jackpot. *This will work. I don’t have to pick another summon partner. I can get started with the construction first thing tomorrow.*

Draining the water in the wetland then, using the vertical drain method afterward would allow him to suck every drop of water stored underneath the peat deposits. Also by accelerating the consolidation phenomenon, the weak foundation would be stabilized and ready to be turned into farmland. All those things, the first steps of his project, would immediately commence tomorrow. Full of conviction, Lloyd clenched his fists. It was time to initiate and reclaim the Maritz Wetland.

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Chapter 46: How to Make Land (1)

“Today, we will turn this place into fertile land.”

Lloyd began his speech. Just then, a frog in the swamp croaked aloud in response.

“Ribbit! Ribbit!”

However, not a single one of the 120 civil engineers gathered in the area smiled. Was it because Sir Javier and Bayern stood beside Lloyd with a grim look on their faces? It might be for some, but for most of them, that wasn’t the case.

I wonder what I’ll go through in this construction.

The ondol, or the heated flooring system, the paved road, the coal mine, and for some, the seokbinggo had been tremendous projects. These experiences along with the storage expansion and dorms for the orc miners to live had transformed these ordinary soldiers.

They were transformed into a group of elite civil engineers who had been trained through numerous construction projects. As such, their past experiences told them how crucial this speech was. *After all, Master Lloyd believes this part of the process is important.* This speech was usually given right before the construction. It was straight to the point with no flowery words. There wasn’t any unnecessary pep talk or empty flattery. Lloyd’s speech was only packed with words the soldiers needed to hear.

“Alright, precautions first. We are working in swamps. So, don’t move around alone at your whim. Just imagine. Bad luck hits you, and you get your feet stuck in the swamp. What do you think would happen after that? This place has zero visibility. Look around. Lots of reeds stand all around us. You’ll become a piece of dry beef jerky scorched under the sun. If you don’t want that to happen to you, move in groups of two. Understood?”

“Yes!”

“Good. Next precaution. It’s hot and super humid here because we’re in a wetland. What do we do now?”

“Take a break every hour!”

“Correct. And what’s another thing?”

“We must drink water with salt every break!”

“Very good. I’ll have the saltwater ready right here, so you can drink that. Don’t stash plain water behind my back and gulp it all down just because you’re thirsty. You’re going to get dizzy and collapse.”

“Excuse me, but what if I find the salt water too bland?”

One of the soldiers asked as he raised his hand, all awkward and clumsy. The number of civil engineers had doubled recently, and he appeared to be one of the new recruits. Lloyd flashed a gentle, kind smile as he looked at the newbie.

“You still have to drink it, obviously.”

“Even if I feel like vomiting?”

“Yes. You can choose not to drink and collapse. But your daily wage for that day will be deducted from your bonus.”

“I will drink it, Young Master!” The recruit agreed immediately.

A lot of soldiers had applied for the civil engineer position for the thick bonus that came after the construction.

“And lastly, this is the most important thing. Hamang will be drinking the water in the wetland. So if I ever find or hear you excusing yourself in the water throughout any time in the construction, I am going to throw you behind bars. Relieve yourself in the makeshift bathrooms. Am I clear?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd!”

“Alright, then, let’s get started. Hamang?”

“Hamang!”

Lloyd brought Hamang out of his embrace. This caused the soldiers’ eyes to widen in surprise. There was a stir among them, and they chatted that their young master seemed to have made a contract with a new summon partner. However, something else happened later that made their mouths hang wide open all the more.

“Hamang? Could you please drink the water here?”

“Hamamang? Hamang?”

“Yes, you can drink it all.”

“Hamang?”

“Aha, after that? Do you see the branch of the course of the river? It’s over there.”

“Hamamang!”

“Yes, you can roll over all the way there and spit it out. But don’t do it all at once. You’ll be causing flooding downstream.”

“Hamang!” Hamang nodded in understanding.

Once Lloyd put him down, Hamang immediately shoved his round face into the water.

The suctioning began.

“Humung!” *Sluuurp! Swooosh!*

Hamang sucked in the water and a whirlpool appeared around him. It looked like a gigantic vacuum was sucking up the water. The water level of the wasteland decreased immediately.

At the same pace, Hamang started to puff up. He continued to grow thirty feet, sixty feet, and even 150 feet tall.

“Woah...”

The soldiers had already stayed far away from the water at Lloyd’s instruction. Their jaws dropped, but that wasn’t the end of their shock.

“Humung!”

Hamang, all inflated and blown up, moved his body, rolling off to the downstream Lloyd had pointed earlier. He resembled a giant 150-feet water balloon rolling away. When he got there, he started to slowly spew the water out.

“Humung! Blergh!”

Splash! Thousands of minnows, frogs, and other living creatures that were sucked in by Hamang came out of his mouth, finding a new home downstream. They became the newbies of the river ecosystem. This whole process was repeated several times afterward. Hamang absorbed the water of the wetland and then rolled his inflated body down to the river. He then spat it all out.

“What am I seeing right now...?” The civil engineers muttered to themselves in a daze, and before they knew it, the water nearby was completely gone.

Of course, other areas needed to be drained as well. Hamang had only drained the water in one area here. However, it was enough to get started with the construction for the day.

Lloyd ordered, “Hold up your shovels.”

“Shovels!”

“From now on, you will get rid of all the grass and other remnants of rotten plants in areas I marked. Let’s get started with a shout.”

“Woah!!”

The soldiers got to work. They shoveled the ground with sweat pouring out of their body. The rotten leaves and roots of aquatic plants were cleared in all the areas where the embankment would be installed.

Lloyd joined in on the shoveling and commanded his men. *If I don’t do this basic process properly, the embankment will leak and erode. Here we go!*

Sometimes, some workers and managers disregarded this process, thinking all it took to build an embankment was to pile up the earth and turn it into a mound. However, that wasn’t the case at all. Even the common embankment you see every day was the product of rigorous science and engineering. The work wasn’t comparable to how children played in the sand. That was especially the case right now. *The foundation here is wet and weak.* Thus, the land required clearing and gruffing. Not only that, the water at the bottom of the ground had to be drained to stabilize the foundation.

“Javier?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd turned around and faced Javier. Javier, who heard what he had to do, immediately got to work. He drew his sword and he stabbed the area on the ground Lloyd had marked.

Swish! Clack! Shank!

The mana circles hit one another and a powerful blast shot out of his sword. The force penetrated the metamorphic layer of rock beneath them. A one-and-a-half-foot wide hole was created, and it went down as deep as thirty-two feet, each hole standing thirteen feet apart.

Lloyd shouted. “Sir Bayern!”

“Yes, Young Master.”

Lloyd shouted, and Sir Bayern answered. He commandeered the civil engineers under him.

They brought with them some bamboo sticks uniformly cut thirty-six feet in length. Then, they inserted the vertical drains Javier had blasted one by one into the ground. The insides of the sticks were hollow like straws made out of bamboo. Next up, it was Ppodong's turn.

"Ppodong!"

"Ppodung?" Ppodong, who was on standby, came running as he waddled his chubby butt.

Something gushed out of his two fat cheeks.

"Ppu-pu-dung! Blergh!"

Splash! It was all of the sand he had obtained in the river.

"Engineers! Transfer the sand into the vertical drains!"

"Yes!"

The civil engineers, who were waiting with a shovel in each of their hands, started to get moving. They charged at the mountain of sand Ppodong had spurted out. They scooped it up and tossed it into the vertical drains. The drains with the bamboo straw in the center became filled with the sand pile.

Good. Everything is going well. The construction site was bustling with movement.

Lloyd clenched his fists as he commanded the whole process. *The vertical drain method, particularly the sand drain method, is working out just as I had wanted.*

This method used to reinforce weak foundations was first introduced in 1936, and it saw massive technological advancement in the late 1940s. To be more specific, the method consisted of drilling long artificial holes in

soft cohesive soil and then inserting plastic drain boards to drain water from the ground to accelerate consolidation.

But, of course, I can't use this modern method as it is. He lacked the equipment to do so.

Thus, he decided to be clever about it. He bore vertical drains using Javier's mana blast.

That was how Lloyd replaced the vibrating sand drain equipment with Javier, the silver-haired knight. Next, he filled them up with bamboo sticks and sand he had prepared beforehand.

So what he was doing was actually a combination of the sand and paper drain method.

Next up was Ppodong. Lloyd ordered him to roll on the ground. "Hey, Ppodong? Roll!"

"Ppodong!"

Ppodong, who weighed several tons, rolled around to his heart's content. His massive weight moved on top of the strata, just like a wet roll of paper towels being pressed. The moisture soaked in the ground began to seep out. It was concentrated near the sand piles planted in the earth.

*Rumble...*The ground started to slowly sink. This place had been a wetland for thousands and thousands of years. For all those years, a huge amount of dead plants sunk into the water, remaining undissolved, and it resulted in a thick accumulation of fibers.

Once those fibers got soaked in a huge volume of water, they created a soft, mushy layer of what was known as peat deposits. However, the pressure from Ppodong was forcibly draining the peat deposits. The evenly placed sand piles accelerated the discharge of moisture all the more.

Squeeze...! The peat deposits got compressed as they drained, and their increased weight made them thicker. The consolidation phenomenon was

taking place. Lloyd then ordered something that would accelerate the phenomenon.

“Hamang? Do you like bamboo straws?”

“Hamang!”

“Will you slurp it up then?”

“Hamamang!”

Hamang closely walked over to the bamboo straws planted around the ground. He then slurped the water pooled around the sand pile using the straws.

“Humung! Humu-mung!”

The water in the strata traveled to Hamang’s mouth in full. Hamang started to inflate like a giant balloon. The added weight put more pressure on the strata. The consolidation phenomenon accelerated. At this point, Lloyd and the soldiers moved to the next part of the construction. It was time to build the embankment that would wrap around the entire wetland.

“Ppodong! Spit!”

“Ppodung! Ptooey!”

Ppodong acted as their dump truck. He repeatedly stashed a huge amount of sand into his mouth and brought it to them. Afterward, the soldiers moved according to Lloyd’s instructions. They busied themselves with their shovels and built a strong foundation.

Of course, they built it just as Lloyd had designed it beforehand.

They should obviously do so. If we stack it up without order, the slope will erode after some time. Or the slope inside of the embankment will be fluidized because of the water leak. Or the piping phenomenon might destroy the slope by causing a landslide. All of these disasters would

destroy the embankment and once it was crushed, the river would overflow and flood the reclaimed land, dooming it to become a murky swamp again.

In short, a meticulous design was imperative to prevent such awful situations that would prompt everyone's happiness index to take a nosedive. The slopes of the embankment were created and smoothened as much as possible. Its height was set to its maximum, taking into account the ground that would sink due to consolidation. That naturally created a difference in the height of the front slope, which would block any incoming river water, and the rear slope which would be installed on the side of the reclaimed land. The sides that would hold the pressure in the rear slope incline were constructed as firmly as possible. Of course, Lloyd didn't forget to press both slopes. The job was entrusted to Ppodong, who wholeheartedly rolled around the slopes.

"Ppo-do-dong! Ppo-do-do-dong!"

Roll! Ppodong perfectly embodied the role of a bulldozer or a roller. Afterward, Lloyd deployed his men to densely plant the grass in a single row. The roots of the grass firmly grasped the earth in the soil. This would prevent the earth from sliding down easily.

To finish everything off, Lloyd told everyone to carefully dig outside waterways to ensure that any rainwater would be drained through them.

After ten days of hard work...Finally, one section was finished. *Woah. We did it.*

Wiping his sweat off, Lloyd looked around himself. The murky swamps that were filled with all sorts of water plants no longer existed. The only thing Lloyd could see around him was dry land and firm embankments. This was it. He had finished reclaiming and building embankments in one area of the wetland. However, Lloyd couldn't stop there. There was still more land to be reclaimed.

"Keep moving! Once we are done, I'm going to shower you with money!"

Encouraged by Lloyd, the engineers moved to the next section. The Maritz Wetland wasn't composed of a single swamp. This vast wetland was instead composed of dozens of irregular swamps that spread all over the place.

Therefore, Lloyd decided to go about the construction, tackling one section, or a swamp, at a time. This geographical feature allowed him to reclaim and construct modules. Plus, the timing was perfect as it was the dry summer season. It hardly rained. The sun was out all day. So no weather could be any more perfect than this one for the reclamation project.

Thanks to that, the construction saw more momentum.

"Be careful of heat strokes! Make sure to take breaks! Give me a shout, and let's get to work on the third section. Go!"

"Ahhh!!"

Lloyd, Javier, the summoned partners, and the engineers all became one for the construction. The process of digging, drinking, spitting, scooping, filling, piling, and pressing became second nature to them. They became skilled at their jobs. At first, the reclamation and construction of one section took ten days. However, with time, that period became shorter and shorter. From ten days, it was down to nine. From nine to eight. From eight to six.

Just like that, three months passed. The embankments got connected to be longer as days progressed, and everyone's arms thickened with muscles. With each drop of sweat on their faces, the murky and humid swamps became drier. Originally, the Maritz Wetland was abandoned land filled with muddy swamps. Nameless creatures inhabited this place and erecting a building or doing farm work was impossible. The land was useless and was good for nothing. Just like that, the Maritz Wetland was treated as if it was nonexistent for many generations. That had been the case ever since humans began to reside in this land. For tens and thousands of years, the fate of this land was unchanged.

Everyone thought that it'd be the same in the future. It had been abandoned, and it would remain so. Just like how the sun rose in the east to go down the west, it was obviously the case. But all that changed now. *Master Lloyd*

changed it. The people in the fiefdom and the baron and the baroness hurried to watch the marvelous scene unfold before their eyes. The useless, good-for-nothing wetland was transforming into a vast stretch of rice paddies and fields.

What's more, this transformation wasn't taking decades for it to be done. It was happening just within three months. The very person who was making the impossible possible was currently with them. *It could be we're experiencing a miracle that no one in history witnessed or thought was possible before.* And just like that...The people's impression of Lloyd was changing once again. Their feelings moved beyond simple courtesy into a sort of respect.

Ding Dong.

[Everyone in the Frontera barony is deeply impressed by the magic-like miracle you have performed. They greatly respect and praise you.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

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Chapter 47: How to Make Land (2)

Ding Dong.

[Everyone in the Frontera barony is deeply impressed by the magic-like miracle you have performed. They greatly respect and praise you.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 450 RP.]

[Current RP: 1131]

Yes! Lloyd clenched his fists. The historical reclamation project of the Maritz Wetland.

Lloyd did get the feeling that the sense of excitement and anticipation in the fiefdom was building up as the construction neared its end. There was a change in the way the engineers and people viewed him. Their gaze wasn't just full of surprise but was mixed with admiration. There was respect in the way they looked at him. So, Lloyd came to naturally expect this kind of reward. *It is just as I expected. This is perfect.*

The reclamation project was a success and he was awarded a whopping amount of RP.

He felt he had become rich overnight. *For the first time, I have over a thousand RP.*

The mere thought of where he should spend and invest the points excited him.

However, he didn't force himself out of his happy reverie. This wasn't any time to bask in joy over some temporary rewards. *This kind of construction needs a good finish more than anything else.* Lloyd lifted his head and looked at the sky. The hot summer was going away. The sky was still clear and sunny, but it felt more distant than before. The sunlight that burned his

and the soldiers' backs throughout the construction appeared to have weakened too. This meant one thing, Autumn was approaching.

It will be raining soon.

The region the Frontera barony sat in received a lot of rain during the spring and late autumn. The summer and winter were dry with comparatively less rainfall.

Thanks to the climate, the reclamation happened in a breeze with barely any rain.

Things will change from now on.

Once it was mid-autumn and the winter approached, the whole place would be battered with rain. At that time, the embankment and water drainage system in the reclaimed land would be put to the test. Meanwhile, Lloyd thought to himself that the drainage facility had to be perfectly constructed.

"When it rains, the water must be drained properly. Otherwise, this reclaimed land we worked so hard to build will be submerged once again."

"Is it because the ground level has lowered?"

"Yup, that's the answer." Lloyd nodded his head at Javier's question.

He went on, "This land was built after we compressed the peat deposits."

The murky wetland was now completely hard because the heavily drenched water in the strata had been completely drained. In the process, the space between the sand particles narrowed, hardening the overall strata and at the same time, they collapsed. It was only natural for that to happen.

"The ground settles as much as the water is drained out."

"By settle, do you mean that it sank down?"

"Yeah, and since the ground level has lowered, the water will easily stagnate when it rains. Thus, it'd be equally difficult for it to be drained."

“That does not sound good. How about we pour more sand to elevate the ground level?” Javier tilted his head as he spoke.

Lloyd chuckled. “No, that method wouldn’t work. Know why? Because the ground here is made up of peat deposits.”

“I am not sure what you mean.”

“Given the peat deposit’s characteristics, the additional layer of earth and its weight would sink the ground again. So it’s in vain even if we add more earth on the top. Similar to how you can go out on tons of blind dates, but you won’t get a girlfriend. It just doesn’t happen like that.”

“What is a blind date?”

“You don’t have to know. Some things just won’t happen even if you try hard.”

“Just like your face, Master Lloyd?”

“Yeah, and just like your insomnia.”

Skillfully parrying the unexpected verbal blow, Lloyd smiled.

“Anyway, that’s why you need a waterwheel.”

The waterwheel used water to power its movement and the Maritz Wetland was surrounded by two currents of the course river. This meant that the waterwheels could be run all year round since water was easily available just outside the embankment.

“Why do you think I dug several waterways in the reclaimed land?”

“To make sure that the stagnated water will flow to one place?” Javier asked.

“Yeah, exactly. I’m making sure that the water will flow to one area. And I’m going to push the water out using the screw-type of pump waterwheel.”

Lloyd happened to be aware of an excellent model to follow to manage reclaimed land after finishing a reclamation project. It was the reclaimed land of the Netherlands, the Kinderdijk.

*Kinderdijk was similar to this place.*That wetland used to be made of peat deposits and the Dutch drained the water and built the embankment after working for a long time. Once the consolidation phenomenon took place, the land hardened and became lower at the same time. When that happened, the lowered ground level became flooded with water.

So Dutch people decided to build a windmill to prevent the deluge, making smart use of the country's geographical features and climate. It was a wise choice because the Gulf Stream that surrounded the land ensured its winter to be warm and snowless and due to the impact of the westerlies, the wind blew hard all year long.

The perfect role model. It's the best source of reference, except for the windmills.

The Maritz Wetland didn't require any windmills. The waterwheel, which used the hydropower of the tributary, was enough. Moreover, the Frontera Barony had a talent who could make a traditional screwed-type pump waterwheel, just like most of the fiefdoms.

"Anyway, the waterwheel construction will begin soon. I already placed an order."

It was true. Lloyd had summoned the talent on day one of the reclamation project. He had prepared a heft down payment for him in advance. *He should be here soon.* The engineer was slated to come today but the man was nowhere in sight. Instead of him, a group of unwelcomed and uninvited guests arrived.

What is that?

From the South of the Maritz Wetland Lloyd noticed a group of people. There were about twenty people, and everyone rode horses.

The engineer? No, they're not.

They were neither civil engineer soldiers nor workers. Among the group of people, there was a guy in the front draped with a fancy cape, riding a white horse. Just then, a portion of the story in *The Knight of Blood and Iron* came to his mind. *Viscount Lacona?* The South of the Frontera barony was home to Lacona viscounty. The novel mentioned in brief that Viscount Lacona was a man of extreme extravagance.

A cape in this weather? Yeah, it has to be him.

While Lloyd continued to think, the unwelcome guests continued to approach. As soon as they closed in on Lloyd, one of the men tossed a question at him without any sort of introduction.

"Are you in charge of the construction site?" The voice came from a man riding a black horse.

He was dressed simply but based on his muscular build, the sword tucked into his waist, and adept horse riding, Lloyd could ascertain that the man was a knight. Javier stepped forward and said, "Watch your manners. This noble gentleman here is Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of Baron Frontera, the owner of the Frontera fiefdom. Who do you serve, and what business does your master have to come all the way here?"

"Lloyd Frontera? Hmm. We have a business with the baron of the fiefdom. Pray, where is he?"

Javier's eyebrow twitched and he had all the right to react that way. He had made it plain and evident that the son of the baron was present. The man, who certainly was a knight, paid no manners to this. Moreover, he even spoke without getting off the horse, unilaterally requesting to meet the baron. His manners bordered on brutishness. However, Javier failed to lash out at the man for his impertinence as he failed to grab the chance to do so. That was because Lloyd immediately cut in before Javier could hurl the harsh words that were just at the tip of his tongue.

"Could it be perhaps that you are Leonero Viscount Lacona?"

“Yes, he is. The eldest son of the Frontera barony better mind his manners to the viscount…”

“Hush. Stay out of this lowlife. The nobles are talking here. Are you Viscount Lacona?”

Lloyd ignored the knight and looked at the man draped in a cape. The knight on the black horse instantly grimaced. The same thing happened to the twenty knights behind him. When he saw their changing faces, Lloyd plastered a bigger smile.

“It is a pleasure to meet you. As my knight has introduced me to you already, I am Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of Baron Frontera. To what do I owe the pleasure of your visit?”

Viscount Lacona stared at Lloyd instead of answering. Lloyd, in turn, locked his gaze without looking away. Silence blared between them as they stood under the fading summer sun. The viscount was the first to break the silence.

“So the rumors are true about Baron Frontera’s eldest son’s eccentric and impudent manners.”

“Have you heard rumors about me?” Lloyd asked.

“Of course I did. I realize that the rumors were indeed true as we speak at this moment.”

“I am honored. My reputation is soaring through the roof.”

“Anyway,” Lloyd went on, “to what pleasure do I owe your visit?”

“I would like to discuss the matter with your father as much as possible.”

“I would like to find out first what your business is as much as possible.”

“Tsk. You always have a response for everything, don’t you.”

“Thank you,” Lloyd said flatly.

“I came to talk about the territory.”

“By territory, what do you mean?”

“This place, the Maritz Wetland.” The viscount spoke, then looked around.

His goatee twitched as he spoke.

“As a vassal to the King, I hold a duty to manage and protect my fiefdom. However, news of misfortune continued to disturb my spirit in recent days. And it pertains to this place, the Maritz Wetland.”

“What news could that be?”

“That the Frontera family is developing the wetland without any prior negotiations whatsoever with me.”

The viscount continued before pausing for a second.

“You would know it, too. That the Maritz Wetland sits in between the territories of the Frontera barony and my viscounty.”

“Yes, of course I do.” Lloyd nodded his head.

It was true. The Maritz Wetland was sandwiched between the barony and the viscounty.

To be more exact, the north of the wetland belonged to the barony, and the southern part belonged to the viscounty.

In a grave, dignified voice, the viscount said, “Therefore, the southern part of this wetland is under my sole right and ownership. Think about it. What is a fiefdom? It is a land entrusted by the great King for governance.”

“Yes, indeed.”

“Thus, whose duty is it to rule over the land?”

“The lord’s.”

“Yes,” the viscount said. “Now we are talking.”

The corners of his lips rose upward in contentment. That got Lloyd to smile bitterly.

He couldn’t hold it. It came out by reflex. *Haha, now I know.* Lloyd had speculations in the back of his mind. So he wanted to hear the viscount out to confirm his suspicions. Lloyd saw through why the viscount, who was living in the south, had come all the way up to visit the fiefdom.

It was for a simple reason.

The Maritz Wetland was useless for generations. But he must have heard that his neighboring fiefdom is developing the place. He’d have been dazed at first but not after he calculated the potential profits. And he’d have decided to wait until the development was over. Why? He wanted to wait until the apples fell from the tree. That way, he could demand that a portion of the land belongs to them. Classic free-riding tactic. What a vermin. He’s a true pest.

These kinds of pests were everywhere. They were like flies that dived into poop whenever they found opportunities to make a profit.

It was the same case in South Korea. The swindlers that scammed his father and destroyed his family were like this viscount. Not only that, the phishing scammers were just the same bunch. It wasn’t exclusive to crimes. Such people could be easily found in daily life, too.

Those sly bastards who constantly took more than their share. Those players stayed safely hidden for the entire game except when it was time for the final kill.

That’s just how the world is. Conscience? This place is rife with selfish individuals whose self-interests come first before their conscience.

Lloyd thought this world wasn’t much different. The Maritz Wetland he was newly developing...He had expected that he would attract a swarm of dirty flies and the viscount right in front of him was one of the pests.

So obvious and plain.

This whole situation was already foreseen by Lloyd.

He had seen through it ever since he first planned the development. *So, in other words, you picked the wrong person to mess with.* Lloyd sneered as he stared at the viscount. *How puny and dumbfounding.* He had shed sweat, blood, and tears to develop this wetland and how dare this viscount try to freeload on him? Lloyd resolved that he had to act extremely ruthlessly to ensure that such a disgusting idea would be completely wiped out from the viscount's mind. However, the viscount was kept absolutely private to Lloyd's swirl of thoughts. He simply kept blabbering, his saliva splattering out of his mouth.

"Therefore, it is only right and proper that you give me the southern half of the Maritz Wetland. Why? Because this holy fief has been bestowed by the great King to me, I must fulfill my loyal duty to look after the land. Am I clear?"

Lloyd didn't respond.

"As such, you must call the baron immediately. Do not make me waste any more of my time."

Lloyd remained silent still.

"Do you not hear me?"

"I do very well. There is just a pest in my ears that's buzzing very loudly."

"Excuse me?"

The viscount grimaced as Lloyd picked his ears and looked around. It was quiet around him.

Was no one there? No, there were a lot of people surrounding him. The twenty knights brought by the viscount, the civil engineers, and the waterwheel engineer who arrived late, were standing around awkwardly. More than a hundred people were gazing at his side.

Everyone remained wordless, their ears ready to catch every word of the conversation.

A huge crowd meant that the game was on. *It's good that people are around because conflicts like these must-have witnesses.* He was happy with the spotlight he was in.

Lloyd brightly smiled. He looked up at the viscount, who was still on his horse.

"I heard you, Viscount. Loud and clear. And what you are claiming as well. As I was listening to you, it just dawned on me that you are well-versed in the art of speaking nonsense. Tell me, was there no one to educate you in your formative years?"

"What...?"

"From now on, we shall have a fruitful time wherein I go over your nonsense one by one to legally illustrate that the words you just spewed are more worthless than dried-up wet wipes."

Lloyd maintained a bright smile as he spoke and with that smile, Lloyd started to barrage the viscount with sharp criticisms, thus beginning the blitz of merciless truth bombs.

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Chapter 48: How to Make Land (3)

It hurts. It hurts even though no one punched, kicked, or whacked me with a club. This numb, stinging pain is real.

Viscount Lacona thought to himself. However, his pain was inevitable. After all, Lloyd had dropped a massive truth bomb on him in front of more than a hundred people. He was caught off-guard.

“Alright, so let’s go over it one by one. You claim that half of the Maritz Wetland belongs to your viscounty, am I right?”

“Of course.”

“And so, you claim that half of the recently reclaimed wetland must be under your ownership, yes?”

“That is right as well.”

“But there is a grave loophole in such a claim.”

“A loophole?”

“Yes,” Lloyd replied. “The loophole is that you have forgotten that this land has been long abandoned.”

“How is that a loophole?”

“For your claim is violating the Royal Land Act of the Kingdom, which the most revered King protects.”

“What...?” The viscount flinched.

Lloyd chuckled. “Land Act of the Kingdom, Title 321. My proof is in the special exemption regarding the development of barren land.”

“Land Act? Title 321?”

“Yes, the act dictates the ownership of barren land that’s been abandoned if it gets reclaimed. Now, let’s walk through the act one by one, shall we?”

“What are you...”

“Article one states the purpose of the law regards the development of long-standing barren land and the establishment of ownership of the reclaimed land.”

“Excuse me?”

“Article two states that barren land is land that has been abandoned for over 100 years without any residential or cultivation activities transpiring on the land.”

“Listen to me first…”

“Article three states that any and all land that meets the requirements listed below will be recognized as belonging to the developer of the barren land. First, the land must be developed with a clear purpose through the investment of capital and labor. Second, the land must be able to support a residential building. Third, the land must be able to support long-term agricultural activity. Fourth, the land must have produced at least one harvest of a crop variety specified by law.”

“Come on, listen to me first…” the viscount muttered, his voice in a rush.

However, such a protest was immediately silenced by Lloyd’s eloquence which spared him no second to rebut

“Article four states that in the case the developed land meets all the requirements listed in Article Three, the land shall be owned by the developer, and it can be registered in the land registry of the Kingdom following the proper procedures.”

“Article five states that the items required to enforce the law shall be determined by the royal law regulations. That’s all. If you want to listen to it

again, please press number one. No customer service agents to help you out, so why don't you shut your mouth and accept defeat?"

Lloyd chuckled as the viscount was at a complete loss of words.

What kind of brat is this?

Viscount Lacona stared hard at him, his gaze dismayed and dumbfounded. The eldest son of Baron Frontera was an incorrigible hooligan. The viscount had heard rumors about this person. Everyone said that he drenched himself in alcohol every day and wreaked havoc on the fiefdom. They also said that reason was recently knocked into him but no one knew what had happened. That's why the viscount had thought lightly of Lloyd. Even when this notorious hooligan stopped him and started to refute his claims, the viscount thought that a fledgling boy like him wouldn't know much of anything.

The viscount had decided to shut this pesky kid up at once and head to meet the baron.

However, it turned out that he was wrong. T*his boy. He's not an ordinary kid.* Lloyd, in fact, was more than ordinary. He may be young, but the viscount knew better now than to try to take advantage of his young age. The viscount would surely go back home penniless.

He swallowed, his throat dry.

There was a law like that in the Kingdom? It is my first time hearing about it. But he's full of confidence, so I doubt he is making things up. Wait a minute. Could it be that he had prepared beforehand because he knew I'd come here? Is that how he studied the law in advance?

At that instant, the hairs on the viscount's arms rose. If his presumption was true, he could not think lightly of this eccentric bastard, who was horrifyingly meticulous. *What is this guy?*

The viscount collected his thoughts. He couldn't back out like this. The Maritz Wetland was a vast land, and half of it took the southern landmass.

This posed a perfect opportunity for him to usurp the land for free. With every fiber of strength left in his soul, the viscount racked his brain. *Think. Find a loophole in that boy's words. Rebut him with a perfect reply...Oh, wait. That's it.*

An idea hit him and the viscount's eyes brightened. With eyes overflowing with confidence, he stared down at Lloyd.

"The Land Act of the Kingdom. That is an interesting story."

"Isn't it? The law is always fair."

"Yes, I'm sure it is. It is fair that it gives a fair opportunity to a person like me. Just like now."

"What is it that you want to say?"

"What do you mean? Well, let me explain it to you. You see, it appears that you have yet to meet an important requirement for this developed land to be yours."

"An important requirement?"

"I'm talking about crops! Crops! Wahaha!"

The viscount smiled in utter satisfaction. He looked like a predator that had found its prey's weakness.

"You mentioned it loud and clear while you were narrating the act. You said that the barren land must meet several requirements in order for it to be regarded as developed. I believe one of the requirements was that the land must have yielded crops at least once."

"Yes, I did."

"Hahahaha! This is why you have a lot to learn, boy! Child, have you harvested any crops in the land?"

The viscount beamed, smiling like a winner. *I won, you brat!* The viscount was content. Here came a fledgling brat who attempted to fight back using the law and the viscount used the very thing against the boy to silence him. Yes, yes, the viscount thought so to himself.

That was until Lloyd let out a scoff.

“That is really funny.”

Not a hint of embarrassment flickered across Lloyd’s face. He only smiled but in amusement.

He looked like a sadist seeing someone struggle.

Putting on a bright smile, Lloyd said, “Actually, I just wanted to show you something. Hold on. Could you please rein your horses to the side? Just a little bit?”

“What...?”

“Two steps, that’s all.”

“What are you...?”

“There you go. Good, good.”

Lloyd stretched out his hands while the viscount was left in dismay. He stroked the white horse’s head and gently tugged the rein to the side, causing it to neigh and move two steps to the side. It happened so spontaneously that the viscount hadn’t had the time to stop him.

“What are you doing?!”

“Please, just a second.”

The viscount protested, but it was useless. Lloyd threw a half-assed answer and bent his waist forward, reaching toward the ground.

Humming a happy tune, Lloyd said, “Whew. Thankfully, it’s unharmed. You have no idea how worried I became when I saw you had to stop your horses right over here out of all the places. I was afraid that you would step on these.”

“Excuse me?”

“Here, do you see this?”

Lloyd, all hunkered down, pointed at the ground. The viscount’s incredulous gaze traced Lloyd’s fingers and there he saw it.

“Weeds?”

“Wrong. It’s onions.”

Lloyd grabbed a chunk of green leaves that sprung up out of the ground and carefully dug the earth, pulling it up gently. A luscious red-brown onion was plucked, looking delicious and sweet. A bright smile formed on Lloyd’s face, the corners rising all the way up to his ears.

“Oh, my. Congratulations. You just watched the greatest moment in the history of the reclaimed Maritz land. Its first crop ever. I won’t ask you to pay for my show. I am not stingy. Anyway, I am so glad the onion grew to a good size, hahaha.”

The viscount’s face darkened. He was dazed. Lloyd brushed off the dirt that had smudged around the onion. He held it out to the viscount.

“So, I’ve proven to you now that we do meet the requirement of having to yield crops. So what now? Here you can take this. You’ve come a long way. Take it as your souvenir. I just think it would be improper of me to send my guests back empty-handed.”

The viscount didn’t take the onion. To be more exact, he couldn’t. In shock, he could only gaze down at Lloyd, trying to make sense of what was happening. The viscount wasn’t alone in his trance. The knights were the

same and no one had time to get angry. Lloyd chuckled and tied the onion around the viscount's horse saddle.

In a firm and cold voice that sounded like nails on a chalkboard, Lloyd said, "Then take care then. Javier?"

Lloyd's voice searched for Javier.

"They are our valuable guests. Make sure you walk them out."

"Yes, your word is my command."

Javier quickly read the room and moved forward. He had already figured out the exact situation. Not only that, he understood more than anyone else the very steps Lloyd had taken to prepare for this moment. He knew because he was the very person who had planted the onions. *Whew...Planting onions was quite challenging.* Javier lightly sighed.

It must have been around the time when they were installing vertical drains. If Javier remembered correctly, it was either the morning after he had drilled holes in the designated areas or the time he told himself that his job in this construction project was finished.

Lloyd had summoned him and given such a random order, *"Grow some onions. Start from today."*

At first, Javier thought this was some sort of a secret signal. He wondered if he had failed to find the special meaning hidden behind those words. However, that wasn't the case as the command was literal. Lloyd was ordering him to grow some onions. When Lloyd shoved a small pickaxe and a bag of fertilizers into his arms, Javier realized once more that he wasn't joking. Of course, Javier felt defiant. Up until that day, he had accepted to work in construction because it was for the development of the fiefdom, but growing onions was another thing.

"*I wonder why you are entrusting me with such a task."*

This task wasn’t fit for a knight as it was a farmer’s job. However, why was the young master ordering him this task? He wanted to find out why, at least. So he asked and Lloyd chuckled and answered in a nonchalant manner. His words were far from being nonchalant.

“*Because the onion you’ll grow may come to protect the Maritz Wetland in the future.”*

What Lloyd said sounded important. He couldn’t just brush it aside and ignore him. Now that he had heard what it was for, Javier couldn’t refuse to obey. *He must have a reason. There must be a hidden motive he isn’t telling me.*

Thinking that in his head, Javier obediently took the pickaxe and the bag of fertilizer. He planted the onions. Of course, the job wasn’t easy as he had never farmed before. *I had no idea that growing something involves so much work.* Javier was an orphan. His parents had died in a war when he was five. If it weren’t for the saving grace of Baron Frontera, he would have died on the streets.

To repay his debt, he gave all of himself to mastering swordsmanship. It was his attempt to fulfill the promise of protecting the lord by acting as his sword. With everything going on in his life, he wasn’t able to gain farming experience and the same went with growing onions.

I had to get a lot of help from farmers.

They offered him endless advice and nagging as well. Thanks to them, he was able to grow onions successfully. Today, that single vegetable saved the reclaimed Maritz land from the viscount. *Did Master Lloyd really predict this situation would happen?* There was no other explanation for his behavior. The more Javier thought about it, the more impressed he was with his young master. However, there wasn’t time to be impressed. It was time for Javier to dance to Lloyd’s brazen and perfect tune.

“I am Knight Javier Asrahan, who serves Baron Frontera. I will escort you out on your way back.”

Javier quickly jumped in with expert manners while the viscount was still lost in confusion.

He then naturally led the viscount and his men before they could voice opposition.

“Let us go, Viscount. Over there.”

“Uhm…”

Finally jostled out of trance, the viscount shuddered, but he was too late. Soldiers and other men that belong to the barony were gazing hard at him, intently paying attention to every word he said and he was completely beaten by the brat’s arguments. What if he continued to persist and refused to move away or blew his fuse, not accepting his argument?

That would be the same as throwing his reputation to the ground. That would be the same as tainting his own reputation. *I got properly served.* Viscount Lacona licked his lips, his mouth growing bitter. He shot a glare at Lloyd before turning away, and he gritted his teeth as he was escorted out by Javier. Once the viscount was gone, Lloyd stood with a content expression on his face, and the soldiers murmured among themselves in excitement as they looked at him.

“Did you see that? Did you just hear that?”

“Of course I did. Viscount Lacona’s face was priceless.”

“He was entirely beside himself. Wahaha.”

“Whew, serves him right.”

“I know, right? How dare he try to steal this land when we endured this murky place to build everything.”

“Whew! You’re right. We’ve shoveled all day to make this land. How dare he try to freeload off us.”

“Zero conscience, really. And Master Lloyd wonderfully served him, that heartless bastard.”

“Gosh, that felt so good! I know I can sleep well tonight.”

The civil engineer soldiers giggled happily. This vast land used to be a murky wetland, abandoned and useless. Who changed this place? They did it with one shovel in their hands and beads of sweat dripping down from an entire day’s worth of work.

This land was the product of their persistent effort and labor under the burning sun. They could never look at the viscount favorably as the noble demanded to give up half of the land for free. They secretly cheered for Lloyd when they heard the dispute between their young master and the viscount. So, Lloyd’s victory felt like theirs.

My young master is the best! The soldiers clenched their fists, their thoughts unified. They were proud and content. The very object of their pride and contentment, Lloyd, grimaced as he looked at them.

“What are you all looking at? Something funny here?”

As soon as Lloyd scolded, the soldiers jumped to action right away. They resumed shoveling at lightning speed, showing zero signs that they were watching the dispute. Since these soldiers worked with Lloyd through various construction projects, they somewhat had some hazy understanding of what Lloyd was like.

It’s bonus time soon! Keke.

Despite his sharp tongue, the young master cherished his men very much. Despite his severe scolding, the young master guaranteed break time. Despite the hard work, the young master gratefully presented each of them with a thick bonus. The soldiers’ faces brightened as they imagined the bonus they would be receiving. The Frontera barony was a rural province in the eastern region of the kingdom. The biggest construction in the history of this fiefdom was waiting for its finale.

But of course, the people didn’t know. They didn’t know that the construction wasn’t over.

That it was just the beginning of a larger transformation. Lloyd didn’t have any plans of stopping. Everything he had done up to this point was for reclamation. From now on, it was time to develop their work.

Before manufacturing the waterwheel to finish off the reclamation project, Lloyd went to the baron to propose a new plan. Once the plan was laid out, the baron nodded happily in agreement. The following day, the barony announced the “The Reclaimed Maritz Land’s Migration Plan.” Upon hearing the plan of his northern neighbor, Viscount Lacona hurled the piece of onion he was fiddling with at full swing against the wall.

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Chapter 49: The Perfect Completion Ceremony (1)

“What did you just say?!”

Viscount Lacona’s arm swished violently in the air. The air brushed against his veiny wrist and fingers. He threw the weighty onion in his hand with full strength. As it was hurled into the air, friction occurred as one side of its ruddy skin slightly latched onto the tip of his index and middle finger.

Just like a baseball thrown by a strong-armed pitcher, the onion started rotating.

Then it drew a trajectory of the two-seam fastball. It flew and cut across the office room, nothing to interrupt its travel and then, it smashed against the wall. The onion was crushed.

Sir Javier Asrahan’s blood, sweat, and tears were poured into this very vegetable. Now, it had turned into an avant-garde pattern on the wall of the viscount’s office. However, Viscount Lacona did not give a hoot about it. His angry gaze traveled toward the innocent administrator.

“The report you just gave me. Repeat it.”

“Oh, yes...”

The administrator carefully opened the paper, and his shoulders shrunk. It was the pamphlet the Frontera barony had produced and distributed.

“As I have mentioned earlier, the Frontera barony distributed the pamphlet which lays out the policy encouraging people to migrate to the reclaimed Maritz Wetland. But what it contains here...” The administrator paused for a second.

“Whew. Keep on reading,” the viscount demanded.

“Yes, of course. The following is the migration policy announced in the pamphlet.”

The administrator started to read.

“All residents who migrate to the reclaimed land will be protected for three years. Seeds of crops will be provided for free, and taxes will be exempted in full. Moreover, in case of a bad harvest year, each household will be provided with the grain worth a meal a day.”

Afterward, he paused and narrowed his eyes into slits.

“Furthermore, those who move to the reclaimed Maritz Wetland are required to stay and live in the land for five years, and external migration during those years will be restricted. Uhm, that part is written at the bottom in tiny fonts,” said the administrator.

“Ugh.” A deep frown was formed on the viscount’s forehead.

His blood pressure surged when he heard it for the first time. And now, the same thing was happening again. He couldn’t help it. *Those nutcases, really!* The viscount could feel that they were extremely serious about this migration policy. Did he think so because the pamphlet listed out the overly generous policies? No. The crux of the pamphlet lay in the last line, which was in very small fonts.

This means that anybody who decides to migrate there will have to settle there for at least five years.

People could move in by volition but not move out as they have to be there for a minimum of five years. That’s how long people would be bound to reside in the reclaimed land. What about the seemingly lavish benefits? *The benefit will cover only the first three years of migration. That’s the thing with this policy.* The protection benefit only lasted three years and yet, the migrants were mandated to reside for five years. What about the two years left once the timeline for the benefits passed?

They must hold up without any support at all. And what would happen on the off chance the farming flops? They’ll have to starve to death just like that.

That was what was scary about the barony's migration policy. That was the very part that made him nervous. However, he wasn't worried for the villagers who might migrate there. His nervousness absolutely had nothing to do with them. He wasn't worried about them because he could already anticipate the villagers' reactions toward the policy.

They will only see the massive protective benefits that will be provided for three years. And those two years where they will have to live without it would be completely brushed aside, even if they know about it. No, they will think that it will be okay. They will believe that they can hold up those two years if they work hard for the first three years.

That was how human psychology worked. People believed that they could do well even if others failed. They would argue that they are the exception even if you showed them countless statistics that proved otherwise. Objectiveness was thrown out the window in exchange for baseless confidence. That was how businesses failed after turning a blind eye to all the dissuading words of concern from others. Some tried out various forms of investing and ended up losing their fortunes. This human mentality was powerful among us. We believed that any risk or burden could be set off by the immediate benefits in front of us.

The barony manipulated that mentality very slyly.

At first glance, the policy was seemingly full of amazing benefits. However, one deeper look would reveal the disastrous burdens one had to shoulder. The peasants would be happy at first once they moved to the wetland but as time passed by, it would hit them that things weren't as easy as they believed. Thus, they would dedicate their entire lives to making the farmlands fertile.

That's what the barony is after in the first place.

The barony's goal was to pressure the migrants in the last two years after alluring them to migrate there with the benefits. This pressure would push them to be at their maximum efficiency and five years later... The reclaimed Maritz Wetland would turn into a perfectly fertile, abundant land. That was why the viscount was green with envy. The jealousy was so raw and sour

that his stomach churned and it became more acidic when he thought about how half of the wetland used to be his possession. *I can't back out like this. The land should have been mine.*

The land was too valuable for him to back away without a fight. He didn't want to give up.

He yearned to take back his portion of the land, come hell or high water before the reclaimed land became settled into the barony's ownership. He nibbled his fingernails.

Just then, an idea popped into his head. *Yes. That's it.* The viscount lifted his head.

Looking at the self-conscious and nervous administrator, he said, "Go at once and bring me the dye workshop supervisor."

A corner of his lips rose as he gave the order. His smile beamed with certainty that his plan would be victorious.

* * *

A few days passed. Meanwhile, Lloyd's plans took place like clockwork and the Maritz Wetland was nearing its completion. Lloyd spread the migration policy far and wide to the people. He received considerably more applications than he expected. Among them, however, some expressed concerns about the migration. Those concerns had nothing to do with the last two years, where they would have to live without the three-year protection benefit.

What if it rains, and the water isn't drained?

They were worried about that the most. Such concern was actually a non-issue. After all, this place had been a wetland for the longest time. As the land sat very low, nearby rivers flooded in each time it rained, creating pools of still water. That was how this land became a wetland, and it had been so since the distant past. However, such a place was turned upside down by human labor. Lloyd and the soldiers built embankments, drained

water, and transformed it into dry land. Even though the migration applicants knew this, they were nervous that it might not hold up.

Besides, they were used to calling this place the “Maritz Wetland,” not “Maritz land.”

This place had always been a swamp ever since they were young. More time was needed to change its impression on people. Of course, Lloyd was acutely aware of the villager’s concerns. So he decided to prepare a show for everyone: The completion ceremony.

“Alright! Get in line!”

It was the day a total of six screw-type pump water wheels would be completed. The baron, baroness, civil engineers, and most residents in the fiefdom gathered up at the embankment.

The heavens must have been on Lloyd’s side, for there was heavy rain. The entire wetland got soaked in an instant. The rainwater stagnated through the meticulously designed drain. And it traveled to the drain facility where the water wheels were installed.

The water in the drain facility entered the waterwheels. The new waterwheels, which still gave off a woody odor, turned with great force. The screwed pump rotated to draw the water up from the drains. Going against gravity, it pushed out of the drain pipes. The water, which was discharged through the drain pipes, gushed out into the river courses flowing outside the embankment.

At the same time, the water level in the drain facility quickly dropped. The waterwheel had properly demonstrated its functionality. Then, the rain stopped and afterward, Lloyd led the baron, baroness, and people to tour every corner of the reclaimed land by foot. Of course, this land was still an empty plain with red clay soil. It was completely empty save for the sparsely grown weeds. However, it meant more than that for the peasants who looked around the place. To them, this land looked more luscious and promising than anything else.

Filling up the empty land with new crops...This was what they wanted the most.

“Honey, don’t you think this place is better than we thought?”

“Yes, indeed. It had rained a lot a while ago, but...”

“No stagnation. I do not even see a puddle.”

“Yes, it is,” the husband replied. “Is it because several drains are installed all over the place?”

“It appears so. But it is amazing. Look how moist this land is all the time.”

“It looks like only the necessary water remained once the excess water was drained during the construction.”

“Yes, it has. Plus, look at the soil,” the wife said as she pointed.

“Let me see it. Hmm... This wouldn’t even need to be fertilized.”

“Right? I have never seen land more fertile than this. It appears anything planted here will grow well.”

The husband didn’t respond, sensing where this conversation was heading.

“Honey, we can’t always live as tenant farmers working for others for the rest of our lives, right?” Her eyes glimmered. The husband didn’t reply once again.

“The kids are growing up now...”

“The eldest one wants to study. For that to happen, he must be sent to the city, but the money is just...”

“I see...I will seriously consider it,” said the husband at last.

The peasants touched the lands and looked at the drain facilities with their own eyes.

The drains were constructed like a spider’s web, covering all corners of the land. Each drain was delicately placed according to Lloyd’s calculations. Thanks to that, no matter how much it poured, the land remained just wet enough without getting stagnated. Just the right amount of water remained in the soil for farming. Anything leftover flowed out through the drains.

Moreover, the soil on this land was excellent for farming. For tens and thousands of years, a huge amount of dead plants and organisms piled underneath the water. As they decomposed, their remnants eventually turned into soil after accumulating in mass over time. Thus, this place was a rich and fertile land that didn’t require any fertilizers with robust and worry-free drain facilities. The fertile land that any farmer would want. The villagers’ hearts pounded in real-time as they toured the reclaimed Maritz Wetland and Lloyd was never going to miss this perfect opportunity. Now, those who were finished looking around the land walked out to leave. However, they found Lloyd nearby, welcoming them. He was sitting at a makeshift table with a paper contract.

“Here. Come over here and take a seat. Enjoyed looking around the reclaimed land?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes. All thanks to you...”

“How was it? Oh, sorry. Do you want some water?”

“Thank you.”

“No problem. It’s hot, isn’t it?”

“Not at all. Uhm, how should I say this? I didn’t feel hot at all going around the land.”

“How so?” Lloyd asked, his one eyebrow raised.

“Because I kept thinking about all the crops I could plant right away,” the farmer replied.

“Haha. Is that how much you liked the land?”

“Yes, Young Master,” said the farmer.

“Does that mean you are interested in moving here?” pressed Lloyd.

“Uhm...Of course, I want to, but...”

“But what?”

“Young Master may not know this, but I am currently a tenant farmer in the field owned by Sir Hans...”

“Aha, you’re talking about the guy who runs an orchard, right?”

“Yes.”

“Why? Did he say that he won’t let you go?”

“Uhm, sort of...” trailed the farmer.

“If that’s the case, say no more. It’s solved. You have heard about the migration policy, haven’t you?”

“Yes.”

“That is officially provided by the fiefdom.” Lloyd leaned back to the chair and grinned.

This made the farmer lean forward toward the table. “What do you mean by official assistance?”

“It means that no one can stop a tenant farmer who wants to migrate.”

“But what about the field I am in charge of...”

“But it’s not like you are going to move in here right away tomorrow, right?”

“Yes, that’s true,” replied the farmer.

“Then you can move after you finish up your job in the land. Hold on, do you want to spend the rest of your life plowing someone else’s land? Is that what you wanted?” Lloyd asked, his voice slightly high-pitched.

“Ah, no.”

“Good. Good. And now you have a chance right in front of you to own your own land”

“Surely, it won’t be easy,” Lloyd warned. “You will have to give your best for the first five years.”

“Yes, I am aware of that.”

“So what now? Do you think you can handle that?”

The farmer remained silent.

“I guess you don’t want it,” said Lloyd and motioned to stand.

“No!”

“No? Are you in then?”

“Yes.”

“Are you sure? You can’t back out. This is your last chance.”

“I will sign it.”

“Good… Since you want it so bad, I guess there is nothing I can do.”

Lloyd slipped his hand under the table, feigning his reluctance. He pulled out a piece of contract paper very skillfully.

Pointing to the items one after one in the contract, he said, “Let’s sign it. Sign here and here and here. Just your name.”

“Uhm, I don’t know how to write...”

“Then you can thumbprint it. Give me your finger.”

“Yes.”

“Stamp here. There you go. Good job. And here next. Good.”

“Thank you.”

“No need to thank me,” said Lloyd. “Starting next year, you’ll find yourself working hard to plow this land.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

“Alright then. Take care. Next!”

The farmer rose from the table and bowed. He went away. Behind him was a long queue of people. Most of them were tenant farmers who didn’t have their own lands. *Good. Reclaimed land migration. This is perfect.* The corners of Lloyd’s mouth slowly crept up.

That day, he signed away all the migration contracts. It was the perfect completion ceremony. On top of that, more rewards followed suit, which he never expected to receive.

[Monumental achievement in construction!]

[Your reclamation of a land that was historically a swamp has been impressive. The Maritz Wetland will now be cultivated by the hard work and passion of the farmers into a land of promise and abundance.]

[You have left an indelible mark in the history of civil engineering on the Lorasia Continent.]

[Your achievement in civil engineering has been recorded in the construction history of the kingdom.]

[A special reward will be given following your monumental achievement.]

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Chapter 50: The Perfect Completion Ceremony (2)

[A special reward will be given following your monumental achievement.]

Lloyd opened his eyes wide. The completion ceremony of Maritz Wetland. It was right after he had finished signing the contracts with all the villagers who wished to migrate here. An unexpected message cascaded in front of his eyes as he was organizing the contracts.

“Is something wrong, Young Master?” Javier asked while helping Lloyd organize the papers beside him.

Javier must have thought it was strange when Lloyd stopped moving and stared into the space out of nowhere.

“It’s nothing, my eyes are just tired.”

“If you are tired, take a short break. I will finish up here.”

“Yes. I’d appreciate it if you do that.”

Lloyd left the paperwork for Javier to finish and he turned to the side, pretending to massage his eyes. As he did so, he read down the messages that floated in front of him.

[As a reward, you have received a large amount of skill experience.]

[The survey skill has been upgraded by two levels.]

[Intermediate Surveying: Lv. three]

[Area that can be measured at once: 3,600 square meters]

[Skill Options: One: Land Cost Appraisal, Two: Subterranean Scanning]

[The design skill has been upgraded by two levels.]

[Intermediate Design: Lv. three]

[Volume of structure that can be projected at once: 216,000 cubic meters]

[Skill Options: One: Map Printing, Two: Floor Plan Marking (Two Dimensional) Three: Simulation Mode]

Wow. What is this?

It was just in time. Lloyd had been thinking of investing his RP in enhancing his survey and design skills. He felt the need to do it as he developed the Maritz Wetland. His current skills proved to be lacking in covering the vast lands and just when he had the thought, he leveled up.

What's more, I didn't even spend any RP. It was completely free.

There was no such thing as a free lunch, people said. Lloyd believed that was crap. He believed that he should drop anything he was doing and run to get a free lunch. That was Lloyd's principle. However, that wasn't the end of his reward. The truly valuable ones followed.

[You have gained a unique experience from designing and constructing a land of massive scale.]

[This experience is having a strong effect on your <Skill: Design>]

[Skill Option Two: Floorplan Marking (two-dimensional) has been enhanced.]

A message about the optional skill, Floorplan Marking (two-dimensional), appeared in front of him. The letters that explained the skill were erased in real time to be replaced with another. The explanation changed according to the following:

[Skill Option 2: Floor Plan Marking (three-dimensional) - You can see the three-dimensional floor plan of your designed output on the actual land. (Note: Only you can see it.)]

Without any words, Lloyd squeezed his fist without realizing it. The skill was nuts, Lloyd thought. *This skill is absolutely and truly overwhelming.*

This means that I can create a complete aerial view of the land in advance if I use this design skill before construction.

A three-dimensional aerial view projected by a hologram would be incredibly realistic.

Lloyd would be able to see all his models in advance. *What's more, I can always modify the floor plan at any time. If I use it with the simulation mode, I can inspect the safety of a structure in real time during the actual construction. Jackpot.* No, the word "jackpot" fell short of the luck he had just found himself in. This was because its potential was infinite depending on how Lloyd used it.

But let's test it out because you never know.

Lloyd quickly turned his head. Javier was on the opposite side, arranging the paper contracts so Lloyd quickly surveyed a portion of the embankment slope. He then designed a simple mud hut in the surveyed space as a test. Then, he added the model of the mud hut he had designed to the embankment slope.

[Design Skill Option 2: Floor Plan Marking (three dimensional) has been applied.]

Points and lines emerged in the embankment slope in real time. They expanded and connected. At last, a three-dimensional hologram of a mud hut was erected.

"Hey, hey." Lloyd stretched his hand and tapped Javier on the shoulder.

Pointing at the embankment slope with the hologram mud hut on it, Lloyd said, "Will you look over there?"

"Excuse me?" Javier turned and looked straight ahead.

"There. Is there anything there?"

"There is the embankment."

“Anything else?”

“The tip of your finger comes to my view. Young Master, you have ugly fingers, which is something I notice often.”

Lloyd stared at Javier before saying, “Nothing else...Right?”

“No, Young Master.”

“Okay. Perfect.”

“Perfect? What do you mean, Young Master?”

“It’s perfect that you don’t see anything.”

Javier cocked his head to the side.

It was a look of absolute confusion. Lloyd became convinced as he looked at Javier.

Even if the optional skill of Floor Plan Marking got bumped up to three-dimensional, it’s only visible to me. Additionally, some more small rewards came. Could it be because he shoveled every day to construct the embankment? One of his tool skills, the shoveling skill, leveled up to basic level three. This meant that his shoveling would consume 20 percent less stamina, the shovel’s movements would become faster and stronger by 10 percent, and there would be a 30 percent less chance the shovel would slip out of his hands.

That wasn’t all. *Even the RP?!* He was given a generous amount. He received five points of likeability with the baron and baroness each, three points of likeability with Javier, and two points of likeability with Sir Bayern. On top of that, his likeability with all the villagers in the fiefdom went up by three points. Thanks to those points, he gained 206 RP.

[Current RP: 1337]

I’m going to be drowning in rewards at this rate.

The reward messages appeared in front of him one after another without any end in sight. Even on his way back home, he had to read through the messages in front of his eyes. All sorts of rewards and special incentives flooded his sight, and it was disorienting. It was the same when he returned to the estate but this time, what welcomed him weren't messages of rewards shown in obscure numbers. Instead, emotional rewards that directly touched his heart awaited him.

"Young Master, welcome."

"Welcome home, Young Master."

"Please let me know if you need anything, Young Master."

The administrator who did the job of the butler, the male servants who were in charge of the physical work in the estate, and the female maids who took care of the housework all tried to beat one another as they welcomed Lloyd. *A long time ago, they used to go aghast and pale every time they bumped into me in the corridor.* They plainly displayed fear, nervousness, and even genuine hatred. They used to flash all shorts of antagonistic emotions on their faces.

Now, things had drastically changed. Their attitudes were poles apart. They smiled as they looked at him. They didn't smile just because they were in front of the fiefdom's young master. Their smiles were sincere and natural, something people only made when they were truly happy to see someone. Lloyd was a bit dazed by this, to be honest.

"Ehem! I am quite charming, yes. Ahahaha."

Lloyd had to put on an embarrassed smile on his way to his bedroom. His awkward reaction was understandable, given that he had never received this kind of treatment before. *Not just in this world. But in South Korea as well.*

He had always been a nobody. He was nothing but a poor college student. It was especially the case when his family was ruined. He absolutely became a nobody. When his parents passed away after suffering from the heavy burden of debt, he became a scum that lived at the bottom of the social

ladder. He was always donned in ragged clothes as he couldn’t dare afford new clothes. He sustained himself with the free rice and kimchi in his dorm. As such, he always looked sickly and his face was perpetually yellow and lifeless. His confidence tanked and his expression became gloomy with it. He never dared to adorn himself in those years.

So, wherever he went, he was barely welcomed. Whenever he had meetings with his classmates in college, he was subtly cast out. Since he didn’t have any money, he never attended special events at school. Group projects flustered him the most. Paying for a cup of coffee burdened him whenever they wanted to meet up in coffee shops. He shook in horror when he learned that a single cup of iced black coffee cost more than one dollar. Thus, he was reprimanded for acting like a beggar by his group mates.

It was the same outside college. In convenience stores, the cashier clerks threw suspicious glances, thinking he was a burglar. The manager of his dorm warned Lloyd not to miss his rent with a sharp glare every time they bumped into each other. Such degrading treatment reached its peak during the time he applied for a part-time job at a lab. He needed quick cash. The part-time job consisted of doing a physiological clinical trial for a new drug awaiting its release. He was locked up in a hospital for a few days, forced to take drugs and sit blankly for several hours while someone came in to draw his blood every hour. He felt like he had become an experimental livestock.

And the only person who welcomed me in those days...Hmm, there was only the old woman from Gimbap Heaven on the first floor of my dorm.

He was a regular in Gimbap Heaven, and he occasionally bought one line of plain gimbap.

Each time he entered, she greeted him by saying, “Welcome, my dear,” and such an ordinary greeting was the most welcoming word in the whole world. That was his life back then but he didn’t necessarily consider it tragic. The fact that his existence was on the same level as a dirty floor mat could be surprisingly taken with nonchalance.

Instead of settling there, he strove hard. He put his nose to the grindstone to make a living.

Day and night, he worked his head off to not fall behind in his studies. He often got at least seven nosebleeds a week from stress and exhaustion. Even so, he clutched to the faint hope that things would be better someday, that his life would turn out for the better once he graduated and acquired his license, and did the best he could in his life. His compact room was his papal cocoon, and he worked his way through his life.

Well, thanks to my life back then, I was able to adapt to this world pretty fast from the beginning.

An unwelcomed presence no matter where he went. Lloyd was used to the glances mixed with aversion and mockery. Even if they were filled with contempt, he was fine. People insulted him that he was a brutish young master. They gossiped that he was a dirtbag, but he was completely unaffected. Compared to the constant ridicule he had to withstand back in Korea, what he went through here was a tiny scratch that made him itch. No, the mere fact that he didn't have to worry about eating three meals a day made him happy. He didn't care if people insulted him or not.

That was how he had felt then, but...*I guess this is what it feels like to be popular...*There were no more glances filled with aversion or ridicule. There was no more contempt or gossip. They were all replaced with gazes of respect and admiration and words of welcome. The same thing happened when he ate dinner with the baron and baroness.

"I hope you came hungry. Here, eat this."

"Oh, okay."

"Do you want to try this?" The baroness urged.

"Oh, sure." Lloyd chewed his food.

"Why are you not eating the meat?" She asked right away.

"I am eating it right now..."

"You need to eat more."

The baroness glued herself beside Lloyd throughout the meal. Whenever she noticed his plate starting to empty, she called the maid and ordered her to bring up various types of meat, bread, fruits, and cookies. If Lloyd dared to eat the salad for two bites in a row, that immediately triggered the nagging from the baroness to eat some meat. *Goodness, I'm going to have indigestion.* His stomach was already warning him. His stomach was so full he felt like it would burst at any second, but the baroness continued to egg him on with no end in sight. She was partnered by the baron, who threw a happy look across from the table.

"It must've been hard to lead a big construction project all this time. Look how much weight you lost."

"Uhm, I didn't lose any weight," Lloyd quietly refuted.

"Yes, you have. Your face is now half the size that it used to be."

"Uhm, that is because…"

"Eat some more. Take big bites. It's not manly to peck at your food with a fork," the baron stated.

"Ugh...I am now…"

"Craving for a grilled duck? Here you go." The baroness cut in.

Kill me instead.

Lloyd wanted to cry, but he did the opposite. He laughed. Though his stomach was strained, his heart was warm. It was especially so when he thought about *The Knight of Blood and Iron* and the ill fate the barony goes through at this point in time.

By now...Originally...Yes, the baroness falls ill.

In the novel, around this time, the baron and baroness could no longer stay in the estate.

They were kicked out of this estate and forced to live as guests in an acquaintance's house.

Embarrassed and ashamed to stay without paying back, the baroness rolled up her sleeves.

She cleaned the house and washed the dishes in an effort to pay back the help they received.

She was someone who had never worked a day in her entire life before then. What’s more, the house owner, who was grateful for the baroness’s kindness in helping out in keeping the house clean and tidy, eventually started taking her for granted, so the house owner tossed more work in her way. This continued from summer to fall until the stress and physical labor from the unfamiliar housework finally made her ill.

It was pneumonia. Every night, she coughed blood. The moldy and murky blanket became soaked with tears. Though she managed to escape death, it was a torturous experience.

Eventually, the baron, who looked after the baroness, contracted pneumonia as well.

Dejected and despaired, the two eventually returned to their original estate in secret.

In the place they once called home, the two ended their own lives right here at this very place where they were having a meal together. It’s a relief that things didn’t pan out that way, Lloyd thought to himself.

It had been about six months since he arrived in this world. Lloyd was relieved that he had been productively spending his time. A sense of relief flooded him that the misfortune in the novel didn’t happen to this family. Just like that, Lloyd was able to smile at ease as he looked at the baron and baroness.

“It’s a bit awkward to keep eating alone. Why don’t you eat as well?” Lloyd suggested.

“No, we have eaten enough already.”

“Do you not like the food?” The baroness asked, wary.

“No, it’s not that, but…”

“Aha! You must want to eat pork, I presume. Just as a man should. Here, there you go. Help yourself all you want.”

“Hohoho. Why don’t you try the steak? It’s freshly grilled.”

I’ll take back what I said about my heart being at ease.

That day, the overeating got Lloyd to clutch his gurgling stomach and make several trips to the bathroom throughout the night.

* * *

The following morning rolled around.

“Ugh...”

Lloyd got up from bed, clutching his spinning head. His body felt like it was weighed down by a ton of rocks. *Is it because I couldn’t sleep well last night?* He had an awful stomach ache throughout the night. Thanks to it, he had to frequent the bathroom several times.

So he was left to roll around in bed but could never fall asleep. *I can’t just laze around in bed all day. Time to get up!* The reclaimed Maritz Wetland was just in its initial phase of development. He needed to hurry and maintain and divide the land before the migration happened. The fiefdom itself and the roads needed repairing as well. In short, he still had mountains of work to do.

“Hey, wake up.” Lloyd, who had gotten up and dressed earlier, tapped Javier on the shoulder.

He smiled, a bit dumbfounded by how the tables had turned, and he was the one acting like an alarm for Javier ever since the lullaby service began.

“Hmphh...” Javier frowned as he opened his eyes.

Lloyd’s smile widened as he heard him.

“You don’t even get out of bed until I wake you up now.”

“Uhm, I am sorry, Young Master,” Javier groaned.

“Forget it. Wake up. We have a lot of work to do today as well.”

“Okay, Young Master.”

Javier fumbled out of his seat. But there was something off about his face. Lloyd cocked his head to the side.

“Hey, you.”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“Is everything okay with you?” Lloyd frowned.

“Yes, Young Master.”

“Then what’s up with that grimace on your face?”

“Ah, I apologize. My head is pounding for some reason.”

“What? You too?”

“Yes. Wait, Master Lloyd, you too?” Javier’s frown deepened.

“Yeah, this headache has been killing me all morning too.”

“Let us have breakfast first...”

Both of them smiled at the ridiculousness of this strange coincidence, but when the maid entered the room later carrying a tray of breakfast, their wry smile instantly wiped off their faces.

“Hey, are you upset? Why are you frowning too?”

“I am sorry, Young Master. For some reason, I’ve had an awful headache all morning...”

The grimacing maid replied as she flinched in surprise. Lloyd and Javier’s faces hardened at her worrying response.

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Chapter 51: We Dig Together (1)

“Haha. Son, what brings you here at such an early hour?”

They were eating breakfast as usual. There was nothing particularly special about the menu either. A loaf of whole-wheat bread and a chunk of homemade sausage. A tiny portion of salad, a fried egg, and a chunk of goat cheese.

The baron and baroness were having a modest breakfast for a noble. They were looking at him, all smiles. But their smiles were a bit different from usual. They were beaming, but there was a shadow overcast on their faces. If their smiles were composed of 100 percent happiness on any other day, right now, they were composed of 90 percent happiness and 10 percent pain.

Lloyd spotted that tiny but significant difference. Without beating around the bush, he went straight to the point.

“Are you,” Lloyd asked, “suffering from a headache?”

“Huh?” The baron flinched.

Surprise washed over him. His gaze wondered how Lloyd had found out.

The baron let out soft laughter and answered, “Haha. How did you know that? My headache has been bothering me since early morning. Isn’t that so, my love?”

“Yes. Maybe we need to change our pillow, seeing as how we both have a headache.”

“Hmm...I have a feeling the problem isn’t just our pillow,” the baron said seriously.

“Then what do you think is causing it?”

“Perhaps,” the baron said, “it is because we are a couple.”

“Are you saying that couples become like one another?”

“Haha, why, I certainly am. How do you understand me so well? We get sick at the same time because I think about you, and you care for me.”

“My, dear, you embarrass me,” said the baroness, her cheeks growing red.

Even in sickness, the baron and the baroness showered, no, bombed each other with love and affection.

Looking at them, Lloyd couldn’t help but smile wryly. The conversation made one thing clear for Lloyd.

Looks like all the people in the estate somehow got a headache.

Lloyd had suffered from a massive headache since he woke up that morning. At first, he thought he was the only one. However, that wasn’t the case. Javier had it, and so did the maid who brought in lunch. The three of them had the same symptoms. A severe, throbbing pain on both sides of their temple.

That’s when the possibility hit Lloyd that there was something more to this. He told himself that this may not be a simple headache. So he skipped his breakfast and came to this place. On the way to meet the baron and baroness, Lloyd checked on the health of the maids and servants he met.

Every single one of them was frowning. Lloyd stopped them and asked if their heads ached.

Everyone gave the same answer. They had a crushing headache ever since they woke up this morning. Now, the baron and the baroness were showing the same symptoms.

There is something behind this.

This situation where everyone in the house was suffering from the same headache… Something was definitely off. But Lloyd smiled instead.

“Haha, all right. Please excuse me.”

“Hmm? Leaving so soon?”

“Yes. I was just stopping by. I still have a lot of things to get done,” Lloyd said.

“Don’t overwork yourself. Make sure to take breaks.”

“Yes. Thank you.”

Lloyd left as the baroness walked out with him. Even then, he didn’t remove the beaming smile on his face. He didn’t feel it was necessary yet to inform them about the current situation. It was too early to report to them.

Right now, nothing’s going to change, even if I tell them about the headache at this point. It’s not like they can give me the solution.

Not only wouldn’t they be able to come up with any solutions right now. The moment he shared the current situation with them, all hell would break loose, and everything would descend into chaos.

First, I need to figure out what is causing this.

He had to know the cause to find a solution. He would tell the baron and baroness afterward.

Thinking that, Lloyd walked out to the hallway.

Javier, who was waiting for Lloyd outside, looked at him with a glimmering gaze.

“How are they both?”

“It’s just as we suspected. The same.”

“Are they suffering from a headache as well?” Javier asked.

“Yes.”

Javier’s expression became darkened.

Lloyd tapped his shoulder.

“Don’t droop your shoulders like a sad puppy.”

“Excuse me? I am not a puppy...”

“Let’s go. We have a lot to do.”

“Yes.”

Lloyd led the way, the two exiting the estate. It was early morning, and the weather was getting ready for fall. They walked down along the paved road that led downtown. The place bustled with people as it had the biggest traffic in the fiefdom. A farmer passed by them to do his morning chores. A woman hauled the goat milk she had milked early in the morning.

A young boy chopped down the firewood for the day. A lively morning view stretched in front of Lloyd and Javier.

However, aside from this, there was a commonality in all of them. A slight frown on their faces.

Hmm…

Lloyd frowned, his forehead wrinkling. They were obviously enduring a throbbing headache.

Lloyd walked closer to a farmer working in the field.

“Hey there, mighty fine morning to you.”

“Oh! Young Master Lloyd?”

The farmer stopped for a moment when he realized who it was. His face instantly lit up. Grabbing Lloyd’s hand right away, the man beamed and said,

“Pray, what brings you here so early in the morning, Young Master? How have you been?”

“How have you been? Lloyd retorted. “We met yesterday. We signed the contract for the reclaimed Maritz Wetland.”

“Oh, yes, we did. Right.”

“So, will you please let go of my hands? Thank you for greeting me, but I’m a bit overwhelmed.”

“Oh? Ah! Whoopsie-daisy!” The farmer jerked his hand away.

Lloyd looked at the farmer with a loaded gaze.

“By the way, do you have any complaints against me?”

“Excuse me? Oh my… Why… I don’t.”

“Then, why are you smiling and frowning at the same time?”

“What? Me?” The farmer’s eyes widened.

“Yes.”

“Are you serious?”

“Yeah, I am very serious.”

“My goodness...It’s just that this terrible headache has been bugging me all morning...I am sorry, Young Master.”

“You’ve had a headache all morning?”

“Yes.” The farmer nodded.

“It’s not just me. My wife and kids, too. Everyone started complaining as soon as they woke up about a headache. But what can we do? It’s no wonder I had a nightmare last night.”

“Aha, you think it has something to do with your nightmares?”

“Yes. I am thinking of praying tonight before going to sleep.”

“Good. Make sure you do that,” assured Lloyd.

“Yes, Young Master. Please excuse me now. I should go.”

“Alright. Hang in there.”

“Yes!” The farmer bowed down before hurrying away.

Lloyd smiled and waved at the farmer, but his expression turned icy a second later. Lloyd turned to Javier.

“It must be the same thing, don’t you think?”

“Yes, Young Master. It appears so.”

Javier's face was serious as well.

“Since it’s not just the farmer but the entire family too, I presume...”

“The same symptom is being experienced not just by the people in the estate but also by the people in the fiefdom.”

Something fishy was definitely going on.

Even after that, Lloyd and Javier went to meet more people. Lloyd cleverly framed the questions so that he wouldn’t rouse suspicion and fear over what was happening. The investigation narrowed to one conclusion: everyone was suffering from the same thing. The same headache. That is, everyone in the fiefdom showed the same symptoms. Lloyd and Javier’s expressions grew serious.

“This is serious. What do you think is the cause?”

“An infectious disease?” Javier speculated.

“Hmm, perhaps. Or it could be something environmental.”

“By environmental, you mean...”

“The only environmental factors that could affect the whole fiefdom would be air or water.”

Lloyd had already been weighing in on the possibility that something in the environment could be responsible for this. He was right to speculate so. The two of them became convinced when they heard from a shepherd boy.

“Yes, my head hurts. But that is not the problem,” the shepherd boy grunted.

“What do you mean by that?” Lloyd asked back.

The boy frowned as if he didn’t know how to explain himself. “My peeps haven’t been drinking water since yesterday.”

“Peeps?”

“Sheep and dogs.”

“Aha, your animals refuse to drink water?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, but I don’t know why. They have been like that since yesterday. I tried forcing them, but they kept turning away.”

“Is that so...? That happens with not just one or two animals but every single one of them?”

“Yes, and it’s driving me nuts. What’s their problem? My goodness,” the boy huffed.

“Okay, I get it now. Thank you.”

“What?” The shepherd boy cocked his head to the side.

Lloyd left the boy and hurried his steps. Walking next to Javier, Lloyd sucked in his breath.

“Whew. I found it.”

“The cause, Young Master?”

“Yeah, seriously, that viscount’s a bastard, really!”

“Excuse me?”

“I mean Viscount Lacona. That man with a goatee who demanded half of the Maritz wetland because he used to rule the southern part of it.”

Lloyd gritted his teeth as he turned back to return home.

“This is his doing.”

“What makes you presume so?”

“Presume, my foot. It’s obviously him with this much evidence,” Lloyd snorted.

He had learned of this information while reading *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Remembering what he learned from the book, he began to speak what he deduced out loud.

“Let me ask you one thing. What was the specialty of the Lacona viscounty?” asked Lloyd.

“Uhm, I believe it’s their beautifully dyed fabrics.”

“That’s right. The fabric possesses a deep, eye-catching color, which doesn’t get washed away easily. But how does the viscounty dye their special fabric?”

“I think I heard it used the Ladona berry.”

“Correct. More precisely, they concentrate the juice of the Ladona berries to dye the fabric.”

“But what does that have anything…”

“Those berries. They induce headaches as they are toxic. The one we are all experiencing at the moment.”

Javier’s eyes widened slightly.

Lloyd continued to explain. “And the Prona River that crosses the fiefdom from north to south. You know how this river passes the viscounty from the south to flow into our fiefdom, right?”

“Yes.”

“There is our answer. Do you understand what I mean?”

“Yes, though I hate to believe it...” Javier trailed.

“There’s no other explanation. The dye workshop uses the Ladona berries, and they dumped the wastewater into the Prona River.”

“Do you mean on purpose, Young Master?”

“Yes.”

“But why...?”

“To threaten us. And what’s more, this threat is extremely effective. No other fiefdom sits to the north of our fiefdom, where the water passes by. It’s just a rugged valley. So by the time the water reaches other fiefdoms far away from here, the toxins are diluted already. This means that we’re the only ones who are directly impacted. So first, we need to head back to the estate as soon as possible.”

Lloyd hurried his steps. Was he hurrying to inform the baron? No. He hurried because he assumed that someone the viscount had sent would have already arrived at the estate, should his speculation be right.

And my hunches are never wrong in times like these.

So Lloyd speed walked back to the estate.

***

At the same time in the baron's office. The situation was unfolding exactly as Lloyd predicted.

There was a visitor who had come to see the baron. It was a knight sent by Viscount Lacona. He was not large but had a muscular build. stable posture and sharp eyes. It was Sir Curno. The senior knight of the viscounty, the guy who blabbered his mouth on behalf of the viscount when they came looking for Lloyd the last time. Sir Curno was arrogantly flapping his lips again, just like before, but at the baron this time.

"My master, the viscount, demands only one thing. It is for you to return half of the Maritz Wetland, which your family has developed without our permission, to the viscounty."

The baron grimaced. "Without your permission? Nonsense. I imagine my son explained it to you the other day. The Maritz Wetland was abandoned for several generations, and we have especially used our funds and workers to renovate it. In that case, the developer gets to own the land by law. Does this still not make sense to you?"

"The viscount does not care much to understand it. Therefore, he ordered us to dispose of the concentrated juice of the Ladona berries from the dye workshop into the river."

"What...?"

"It is just as I said. Have you not been suffering from a splitting headache since this morning? I think this clearly sends the viscount's message.

"What is that supposed..."

"Listen carefully. I will spell it out for you. The viscount declared that he would not stop dumping the Ladona berry concentration until you forfeited

half of the Maritz Wetland. I am sure the baron must know very well, given your status. What side effects the toxins from the Ladona berry can cause, that is."

"What do you say? Are you starting to think about giving us half the land?"

"Sir Curno. Let me ask you one question. Could you possibly be blackmailing us right now?"

"Yes." Sir Curno nodded explicitly.

The baron became speechless and a second later, he gritted his teeth and said, "This is such a pathetic threat. It appears that your master has no fear of the law. Did you think that this would make us succumb and give you half of the land my son has worked so hard to restore?"

"You will have to eventually," the knight said coolly.

"I shall file a complaint to the Royal Court before that happens."

"By all means."

"What?"

"Do it, I said." A sneer escaped from Sir Curno. "You can sue us. Fine, it is fine. You may win at the end of the day."

"And yet you are not scared of it?"

"Not at all. You will not be able to hold on for that long."

"What..."

"It is going to be at least a year until the trial comes to an end. And the Royal Court is notorious for being expensive. Are you still confident that you will be able to hold on all those months?"

"I reckon your financial situation is not very bright at the moment."

There was explicit contempt in Sir Curno’s gaze. The baron unknowingly bit his lips.

What is this... He wondered if this was what it felt like to be smacked in the head with a hammer. He was enraged but he couldn’t think of anything to respond with.

The only available recourse was to sue them and bring the matter to the Royal Court.

But as though they had seen it already, the knight was mocking him over it.

What should I do? The baron felt stuck. Come to think of it, the knight was speaking the truth. His financial stability was at rock bottom. Even though Lloyd had been resorting to various means and helping him pay off the interest, the future was still bleak for the fiefdom.

If they had to shoulder the fees for suing the viscounty at the Royal Court on top of everything? *We won’t last.* The baron strove his best to make the most objective judgment.

However, the only conclusion seemed to be that a lawsuit would be too much. His barony wouldn’t be able to last a long and tedious legal fight. *It is not like we can keep drinking toxic water.* Enduring the headache was far from possible. Right now, the residents in the fiefdom probably thought that this was just an ordinary headache.

Once the cause for their headache was revealed over time...*It’s impossible to live without drinking water from the river. People won’t just put up with these painful headaches. Eventually, they will migrate to another fiefdom one by one.* He knew where they would go, the viscounty. So right now, his fiefdom was left helpless to fight back. Therefore, the baron thought there was only one way to avoid the worst scenario. *Is succumbing the only option I have?* His train of thoughts arrived at one destination which was to give what they wanted, half of the Maritz land.

The baron found himself clenching his teeth. If he could, he wanted to throw a punch at Sir Curno in front of him. However, he couldn’t as he was

the weak one. He was in the position to give what they wanted. He had no other choice, given that the life of the people and the stability of the fiefdom were at stake.

Fine. It was originally a useless piece of land anyway. I should be thankful that we get to use even half of it.

Rage rose in him, but he could not do anything about it. *I must be content with this.* He controlled his boiling emotions. He lifted his head and looked at Sir Curno, who was still sneering at him. After hesitating a few times, he finally opened his mouth.

“Whew. Okay, I will give...”

“You the middle finger. Scram!”

Just then, the door of the office room slammed open. The baron and Sir Curno jerked up and gazed at the door. There they saw...

“I am sorry. I was a bit in a hurry. I was talking to that man over there.”

Lloyd was panting and sweating as if he had run all the way home. He plastered a wry smile and pointed at Sir Curno. He spoke aloud the plan he had prepared on his run to the estate.

“There is a way where we won’t have to hand over the land to those pests. I will walk you through it slowly, so why don’t you kick out that haughty troll first? Better if you beat him before he leaves.”

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Chapter 52: We Dig Together (2)

“There is a way to escape this situation without handing the land to those pests. I will walk you through it slowly, so why don’t you kick out that haughty troll first? Better if you beat him before he leaves.”

“What...?”

The baron was taken aback by Lloyd, who had kicked the door open as he entered. The baron found himself engulfed in despair and dejection due to a persistent headache that had commenced in the morning. Sensing an unusual occurrence, he could not quite grasp the extent of it until he realized that Viscount Lacona was the orchestrator behind the unforeseen events. As such, he was caught unaware by Sir Curno’s message from Viscount Lacona. His message was clear: the viscount would wittingly dump toxic wastewater from the dye workshop into the river. That wastewater would make everyone in the fiefdom suffer from a headache.

That’s going to last until I hand over half of Maritz land to him?

The viscount was demanding half of the Maritz land from him. The viscount made it clear that he planned on continuing to dispose of the water until his wish was granted. It was a threat, an explicit and unreasonable one. However, the baron lacked ideas on how to fight back. He warned that he would take the matter to the Royal Court, but it was useless. Sir Curno had only responded back with a snicker and questioned if he could last through the trial. He was angry and mortified.

However, his hands were tied. Of course, aside from taking the matter to the Royal Court, he could request for a “fair arbitration” with Count Cremo, the great lord who ruled over this province. However, that hardly looked like a promising idea. *After all, there is no way Count Cremo will actively resolve the dispute.* Heck, there was even the possibility for the wealthy Viscount Lacona to bribe the count behind his back. That would spell results worse than raising the white flag. In situations like these, the world was likely to side with the rich and powerful, not those who were in the right. That was the dirty way of the world. The baron sighed thinking about all of this.

The situation was very bad as this was a fight he couldn’t win. So, at last, the baron decided to come to grips with reality. He persuaded himself that this was all for everyone’s sake in the fiefdom, that he was making a reasonable choice before the situation worsened. After all, he was left with no means to fight back. Just when he was about to voice his defeat to Sir Curno, Lloyd barged into the office.

“What? What do you mean? And how do you know what we’re talking about?”

The baron jumped out of his skin. This exchange unfolded within the confines of his office, occurring directly between Sir Curno and the viscount himself. What’s more, it was being discussed in real time. So there was no way or time for the talk to be leaked outside the room. As such, it shocked the baron to see Lloyd being aware of the discussion between him and the knight. He wondered for a second if his son had been eavesdropping just outside the room. It seemed far-fetched as Lloyd was soaked in sweat from head to toe, completely out of breath. So it had to mean that he ran over here in a rush.

“Huff, huff. Thank goodness. It appears that I am not late. There’s no need to be surprised. I surmised this would be happening after going around the fiefdom trying to figure out what is causing headaches.”

“You surmised it?”

“Yes. Tell me, this man here was threatening you just now, wasn’t he? How the viscount plans to toss the toxic wastewater of the dye workshop into the river should we not give them the Maritz land.”

Lloyd’s speculation hit the nail on the head. The baron clamped his lips.

Lloyd went on. “So I say this again. We must never give them the Maritz land, not even an inch of it. No, we don’t have to hand it over at all.”

“The reclaimed land? To Viscount Lacona?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd wiped the sweat dripping down from his forehead to his cheek. Collecting his breath, Lloyd walked into the center of the room and stood face-to-face with Sir Curno.

He stared into the knight's eyes and said, "Why should we concede to freeloading beggars who are trying to usurp the land we worked so hard to develop?"

Could it be that Lloyd's words provoked him as Sir Curno's eyes flashed with anger? Lloyd disregarded the change in the man's emotion and continued.

"So there is only one answer we should give them. It is to tell them that they must put in the hard work themselves if they want more land and don't even think about leeching off us like a clingy parasite."

"Wait, are you speaking to me right now?" retorted Sir Curno, his lips twitching.

Lloyd's lips curled up into a sneer. "That's right. You know, you're pretty smart for a parasite."

"Are you insulting me right now?"

"Oh. It looks like you can take a hint as well. Do you want a pat on the back?"

"You are making a mistake here," Sir Curno snarled.

"Aha. I know what you are saying. You are here to send the message to the viscount, and since you represent him, mortifying you is the same as mortifying the viscount. That's it, right? But guess what? I am insulting your viscount."

"Do you mean that?"

"Yes."

Lloyd’s voice was so confident and laid back that Sir Curno found himself at a loss of words.

Meanwhile, Lloyd kept whamming the knight with his willy insults.

“Hey, let’s be honest here. Aren’t you a bit tired? Come on. Are you sure you’re fine when you’re serving that kind of master?”

“My lord is, of course...”

“A corrupt man,” interrupted Lloyd. “The man will live the rest of his life without even bothering to fix his conscience.”

“No, but I...”

“Yet you can’t cut him out of your life? Really? Do you still have loyalty left for him? I guess you’ll never need to move up north.”

“Why would I go north...”

“Because things are going south for you.”

The knight clamped his lips.

“What do you say? Have a slight change of heart?”

“No, not at all. Lloyd Frontera. You continue to greatly insult my master by making a joke out of him.”

“Tsk, tsk. Bastard, you’ve changed your entire attitude in a split second.”

“So scamper back to your fiefdom and tell your master this loud and clear. We are not handing over the Maritz land. We will not concede with even half of it. Heck, not even an inch of the embankment or a tiny speck of the soil will be given to you.”

“We shall be throwing away the wastewater into the river then,” Sir Curno reminded. “I suppose this does not scare you at all.”

“So what if you do that?” Lloyd rolled his eyes. “Hey, man. I’ve survived working for an entire year breathing in asbestos without a mask.”

“What are you saying...”

“Got anything more to say? Goodness, you are clingy! Go now. Be gone.”

Annoyed, Lloyd made a shooing motion at the knight. Sir Curno’s face instantly grew icy.

“You shall regret the behaviors you have shown today,” he warned.

“Who cares?”

The knight was dumbstruck.

“What? Something wrong?” Lloyd mocked.

Sir Curno remained silent.

“Good gracious. Why are you still here?!”

“Haa...We shall see how this goes.” Sir Curno spoke and turned back, the muscles in his jaw twitching.

He slammed the door shut as he left. The banging noise jostled the baron out of his trance.

He grabbed Lloyd’s sleeves.

“What in the world...Are you sure this will be fine?”

“Excuse me? What do you mean by fine?” Lloyd asked casually.

“I am asking if we do not have to worry about what comes next. We not only turned down the viscount’s request but also humiliated his messenger.”

“Yes, well.” Lloyd grinned.

It was a huge relief for him. He was glad he was suspicious of his headache this morning and worked hard to find the cause of the pain. He also came up with a solution on the way to the estate.

“I told you a while ago. I have a plan that will save us from handing over the Maritz land to those people.”

“A plan? Let me hear it. But first, let us sit down.”

The baron got Lloyd to take a seat. Once Lloyd, Javier, and the baron sat at the table, the disordered atmosphere in the room died down into calmness. The baron’s head cleared as well.

“Yes, it appears that you do have a sure-fire plan, given your confidence. Am I right?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded his head.

“Things have gone this far. So let us just lay a water supply in the fiefdom,” Lloyd said.

“Excuse me?” The baron cocked his head to the side.

He didn’t know what Lloyd meant by this water supply.

“Please explain more.”

“Uhm, to put it simply, I am talking about using the pipes to directly source clean water from a distance right into the fiefdom.”

“Clean water from a distance?”

“Yes,” Lloyd spoke and nodded.

The baron furrowed. “Bringing in water...I have never heard of such a method before.”

“I have been thinking about it for a while.”

“You have?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded again after he replied.

In actuality, he lied about that part. The classic water supply system was a technology the Roman Empire employed during ancient times in Lloyd’s previous world. Rome introduced a system that allowed them to draw clean water from a distance into the city, and the empire managed to prosper without any shortage of water needed for living. Lloyd planned on introducing that water supply system now that he had the chance to. Of course, he didn’t forget to be thick-skinned about the whole thing.

“Sometimes, I wonder to myself. There are times when we struggle because we solely rely on the river branches for water, right?”

“Hmm...That is right,” the baron agreed.

“Yes. When there’s a drought that dries up the river or a flood that makes the stream muddy, it gets hard to drink the water. That’s why I always thought that it would be nice to build an intake station where water could be stably supplied all year round so that we can draw water from there.”

“Hmm, that is certainly an excellent idea. However...”

The baron cocked his head to the side and asked, “Do you know how to build such a thing?”

“Yes,” Lloyd replied. After all, I have been thinking very hard, nonstop, and passionately about this.”

Not me, of course, but countless civil engineers who lived in the ancient days.

Lloyd brazenly answered without including the last part but the baron’s face was still dark with little sign of brightening. Even if the amazing water supply system was built, there still existed the ongoing conundrum that troubled everyone, and that would take some time to resolve.

“Yes, your idea is truly outstanding and bold as well. However, I am still worried. I suppose this water supply system will take quite a lot of time to complete, right?”

“Yes.”

“Then where should we source clean water for the time being?”

The method to acquire clean water right now was the part the baron was concerned about.

Regardless of how fantastic the system was, it was useless until its completion and it meant that the people would have to drink from the poisoned river and live with severe headaches until the water supply system was fully built. The baron’s concern, however, was unnecessary. After all, Lloyd had thought about the issue already. What’s more, he even had an answer for it.

“There is also a solution to that.”

“A solution? What is it?”

“Do you remember my summoning partner Hamang?” asked Lloyd.

“Oh, the summoning partner that grows into a giant once he drinks water but who is breathtakingly round and cute on normal days? The pink baby hippo with peach fuzz on its sides?”

“I see that you remember even the littlest details.”

“Ehem. Hmm! I find him quite cute.”

“Anyway, I suppose you plan to use this summoning partner?” asked the baron.

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded his head.

“I am going to have Hamang carry a large amount of water. We will fill up a temporary reservoir with it.”

“Amazing as usual. That would resolve the water shortage even when the construction for the water supply system is going on.”

“Yes. Speaking of it, I have a request to make before I begin this project.”

“A request? What is it?”

“I want you to issue a declaration to the villagers under your name as the lord.”

“A declaration?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd continued to explain. “Then, lend me your ears for a second… So… Blah blah blah… Blah blah blah... Yes.”

“Hmm, amazing.”

Lloyd explained with fervor while the baron nodded. Meanwhile, the anxiety that washed over the baron started to fade away and later, it was completely gone. His confidence in Lloyd slowly grew. This dispute he had thought he was too disadvantaged to win...The tables were turning now, and he even started to have some hope of getting revenge.

* * *

That afternoon, the people in the Frontera fiefdom read the lord’s declaration. It was concise. It revealed, in brief, the cause behind the headache everyone was experiencing.

“What? So we have been suffering from headaches all day because of Viscount Lacona?”

“That’s what I’m saying.”

“Where did you hear it?”

“Where else? I read it in the declaration the baron has issued.”

The farmers, woodcutters, shepherd boys, women, and the neighboring grandmothers all read the declaration. The contents of the declaration spread in a flash.

“Did you hear? It’s about the dye workshop. The river’s been polluted with toxic waste from there.”

“Oh my! Was it by mistake?”

“No. On purpose.”

“Dear me! That is nuts. What kind of humans are they?!”

“I was thinking the same thing. What is more, the viscount demanded something strange from the baron.”

“A demand? What could he have demanded?”

“Do you know the Maritz land?”

“Of course, my son is a civil engineer soldier there.”

“He asked for half of the land.”

“The viscount or whatever said that?”

“Yes.”

“What kind of demand is that?! My son spent all this time shoveling under the sun to build that land! Hand it over for free? Dear me, the world has come to its end for sure!”

“Yes, indeed.”

Rage swept over the fiefdom. Some cursed the viscount as they clenched their fists in rage.

Another angrily complained, asking why they were letting the viscount lash out at them. Perhaps that’s why when news spread the following morning

that Lloyd Frontera was starting a construction project to overcome the river poisoning incident, most people who had enough strength to work volunteered to help, with the number of recruits reaching an unprecedented level.

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Chapter 53: We Dig Together (3)

“Young Master Lloyd!”

“What do I have to do?!”

“My lord! Give us something to do!”

“We brought everything we have, our shovels, pickaxes, and everything!”

“I also brought my sons!”

“We came as a couple!”

“We are here, too, oink!”

The area was bustling with people. It was early morning. It was normally a tranquil time people used to get ready for the day. It was when people ate breakfast amid the fog of the early fall and washed their faces as they stretched their slightly stiffened bodies.

However, today was different. There was a noisy crowd in front of the baron’s estate. Hundreds of villagers assembled in the area. Each shouted aloud, raising up their shovels, pickaxes, and other tools. At first glance, the scene resembled a peasant revolt that would instantly make any lord turn pale as a sheet. However, that wasn’t the case. It wasn’t a revolt. It was a group of villagers who gathered up to volunteer for the construction. Baron Frontera looked outside through the window in his office and became aghast.

“Did you expect this to happen?”

“Hmm...To be honest, I never thought it would be this much,” Lloyd confessed.

Lloyd gave a wry smile in response to the baron’s question. It was true. He had absolutely no idea that the declaration issued the previous afternoon

would be this impactful. Lloyd had suggested to the baron to write the declaration. He advised the baron to transparently inform everyone about how underhand Viscount Lacona was and what he demanded using his threat.

But the baron turned out to be a better writer than I imagined.

To put it plainly, the baron had an amazing talent for writing. It was just a regular announcement, and yet it tugged at the readers' heartstrings. When Lloyd read through the declaration, he found his heart pounding with emotion. He clenched his fist in anger, and his throat choked. If it had such an effect on Lloyd, who had grown cynical as a result of his difficult life, it was no brainer what it would bring about once the naive farmers read it.

Maybe the baron was born at the wrong time and in the wrong world.

Just then, Lloyd wondered what would have happened to the baron if he had been born in South Korea. He wondered if he might have become a popular author on platforms like NAVER. Pushing such a trivial thought aside, he spoke. "Regardless, the declaration had a great impact. It appears that our work will go smoother."

"Do you mean the one we talked about yesterday?"

"Yes. I am thinking of starting the construction for the temporary reservoir right away."

The time was ripe as there was an enthusiastic atmosphere among the villagers. A sense of commonality was formed among them, the rage against the viscount binding them as one.

It would be a waste if Lloyd missed this time. No, he would be a fool if he did. Lloyd went out of the baron's office right away, exited the estate, and stood in front of the people.

He didn't give a speech filled with unnecessary flowery words. Without any words, his actions revealed to everyone what would come next. He raised a

metal shovel in front of everyone. It meant only one thing. The start of the construction!

The human villagers and orc miners. Everyone lifted their shovels as high as they could.

They followed Lloyd, walking across the fiefdom. No, they weren't walking, they were marching. Lloyd pointed at a spot and they got to work right away. Lloyd had already finished surveying and designing the area they were in the night before. Lloyd brought out Ppodong first. He fed a red sunflower seed to him.

"Hey, Ppodong."

"Ppodong?"

"Time to eat."

"Ppo-do-dong!"

Ppodong grew thirty feet. The people cheered at the appearance of the most reliable heavy equipment, the summon partner. Basking in the cheers and praise, Ppodong began to burrow the ground.

"Ppo-do-do-dong!"

His chubby fat wriggled, each time bringing his huge forearms to move like the wind. The ground was excavated in huge scoops. The dirt explosively splattered in all directions and about thirty minutes later…The empty lot formed a rectangular pit whose width, length, and depth were 164 feet, 328 feet, and eight feet, respectively. It looked like a swimming pool. Lloyd gave out his next instructions.

"Alright, the first group of civil engineers will refine the pit Ppodong has dug. Flatten the surface and shape the corners at a right angle. Let's go!"

"Yes!"

The soldiers in group one threw away their shirts and jumped into the pit. Lloyd's gaze traveled to the ordinary residents in groups.

"Alright, group two and everyone else. Find flat rocks and bring them here! The larger and wider, the better. Do you see this? Rocks flat as these are the best. Make sure you don't get hurt. Don't overdo it. Okay?!"

"Yes, Young Master!" everyone shouted.

The people began to move around. The work wasn't divided by gender or even occupation.

Old farmers, young woodcutters, shepherd boys, and hunter girls spread around in search of flat rocks. One brought a rock as large as a dining table, while another brought a pile of palm-sized rocks. Even the small, waddling children brought tiny stones in their little hands, their other hand holding their mother's. Lloyd joined them to collect and gather the rocks.

About two hours later, thanks to everyone's efforts, a large pile of rocks was stacked beside the rectangular pit.

"Great. Groups one and two, and the villagers should take a break. Group three and the plaster workers, transfer the rocks into the pit and carpet it on the ground and the sides. Let's go!"

"Yes!"

Group three and the plaster workers moved. They laid the flat rocks as though they were laying tiles in a swimming pool. They laid the rocks and they plastered them with mortar.

Of course, the job wasn't done haphazardly.

"Over there! Too high! Lower it! Maintain the slope!" Lloyd instructed.

This facility was meant to be used as a temporary reservoir. It was the place to store potable water for everyone and for hygiene's sake, the water needed to get drained.

As such, Lloyd made a slope in the ground. It was the same when he instructed the others to lay down the rocks and make a drain where the water would travel outside through the reservoir.

It's obvious. Otherwise, the water will stagnate.

Stagnated water would rot. It wasn't an exaggeration. Moreover, the rotten water would fester with various bacteria and algae. Anybody who thoughtlessly drank from it had a good chance of contracting all sorts of diseases. That was why the importance of the drain system of the reservoir could not be driven home enough.

"Alright. Orcs, bring in the rock for the sluice gate!"

"I have been waiting for this moment, oink!"

Lloyd shouted after creating the drain. The orcs, who had been dying to get to work, yelled back. Three orcs walked in, carrying a huge rock the size of an elevator. They set it down at the area that connected the reservoir and drain. The size of the rock fit just right with the drain, like the cork cap to a wine bottle. This rock would serve as a cap that keeps the water locked in the reservoir. When the water in it had to be drawn out, Lloyd could allure these gym rat orcs to slightly lift the rock up. With that, the 184 by 328 feet swimming pool, no, the temporary reservoir was completed. The construction had kicked off in the morning, but it took only half a day for it to be finished.

Woah. The speed of construction is unreal.

The residents hollered. Lloyd clucked his tongue amid the excited cheers. However, he still had more work to do. Now that the reservoir had been made, it was time to fill up the empty space.

"So, wait here, everyone. Oh, right. You might get stomped by Hamang if you're too close to the reservoir. So take a couple of steps back. Javier?"

"Yes."

“Come draw some water with me. Bring the horse.”

“Understood.”

Lloyd hopped on the horse Javier was on. They galloped south, following the river branch of the Prona River that divided the fiefdom north and south. They passed the reclaimed Maritz land and the Lacona viscounty. Eventually, they arrived upstream where the river water wasn’t contaminated. Lloyd placed Hamang down in the clear river.

“Alright, Hamang. You know what to do, don’t you?”

“Hamang!”

Hamang’s eyes were shining the moment he laid his eyes on the flowing river. He shook his butt in excitement. He looked like a puppy about to go on a stroll he had been waiting all day. He was super ready to jump right into the river. Lloyd gave exactly what Hamang so badly wanted.

“Okay, take it in one shot!”

“Hamang!”

Hamang threw his fist-sized body into the river but he didn’t flow down the river with its current. Instead of him, it was the water level that started to go down.

“Hamamamamang!”

He quite literally devoured the water. Sucking in the river water, Hamang grew gigantic in real time. He grew to an incredible size, going over his previous 160-foot height record. He was ninety-five feet tall now.

Good. His one-shot skill has improved more as he reclaimed the Maritz Wetland.

Hamang’s one-shot skill level was three. It increased by two levels. His previous maximum height was one hundred and sixty feet, but now, it was

one hundred and ninety-five feet. Specifically, this meant that he was able to store almost twice as much water in his mouth.

“If you’re done, let’s move! Off we go!”

Lloyd tapped Javier, who was sitting in the front saddle, on the shoulder. Javier spurred his horse. She gave a neigh and galloped at full speed. Behind them, Hamang followed as he rolled and smashed everything in his way with his body.

“Hamamamamang!”

The 195-foot tall living water balloon rolling forward was a terrifying sight. Perhaps that was why Javier’s horse ran at full speed and Lloyd learned what it would be like if his pelvis got dislocated and smashed on the saddle. A strong impulse swept over Lloyd at one point.

I want to make Hamang charge right into the viscounty.

He wanted to go into the viscounty with his blood ally, the Sand and Steel orc tribe. However, he fought against the idea. The bad guy was Viscount Laconat and the people living in the viscounty were innocent. So Lloyd didn’t want to unnecessarily harm them out of anger. Besides, realistically speaking, such behavior could bring about disastrous results. It would obviously be the case legally or financially.

“Alright, this way!” Lloyd instructed the way to go as he clutched Javier’s shoulder from the back of the saddle.

Unlike the road he had taken coming up here, this route took a detour around the viscounty.

At last, they safely arrived at the barony. The people cheered and shouted for joy at Hamang’s grand appearance. When the water Hamang spewed out of his mouth filled up the reservoir in one go, overfilling it to be exact, the cheer developed into a roar. They roared because they now had enough clean water for the foreseeable future. *Of course, this is just a temporary measure.* Countless people roared in excitement.

Lloyd didn’t allow himself to be carried away and lose his composed expression. Instead, the work he would soon have to do flashed through his mind.

I was able to finish building the reservoir because more people joined the project than I expected. It’s good but not enough. Temporary measures have a limit.

Building a reservoir and mobilizing Hamang to fill it up with clean water looked like a good solution at first glance. But. it had a flaw and that was that this required him and Hamang.

Hamang only listens to me because he’s a summoning partner. It’s not an understatement to say no one can control him. This would mean that Hamang and I must regularly go up to fill the water in there.

In other words, he wouldn’t be able to vacate the fiefdom for more than a few days. If something happened to him or Hamang and the reservoir didn’t get the water it needed as a consequence? Everyone would suffer from headaches after drinking the contaminated water again. *That’s why this method is a temporary solution. I must build the water supply quickly.* Time wasn’t on his side and he didn’t have the luxury to idle around.

So, Lloyd began preparing for the water supply system construction the following day. First, he began by surveying the site. He climbed the eastern range of the land with Javier.

Their destination was clear.

“We are going all the way up to Lake Kapua,” Lloyd said as he climbed the uneven mountain road.

The lake sat in the mountain, and it was located halfway up to the eastern range. Javier cocked his head as he trailed behind Lloyd. “I see Lake Kapua. But I have a question, Young Master.”

“A question? What is it?”

“Out of all the lakes, why did you choose Lake Kapua?”

“What do you mean by that? Is there a problem?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, there is,” said Javier gravely. “Have you ever heard of King Storma?”

“King Storma? Of course, I did. I heard he’s a very strong and ferocious monster.”

“Then, do you also know that the lake is in the monster’s territory?”

“Yeah.” Lloyd nodded his head.

He added, “I also know that King Storma is currently in hibernation.”

“Hibernation?”

“Yeah, he’ll probably be sleeping for the next fifty years or so,” said Lloyd.

“How do you know that?”

“The knight of blood and iron told me,”

“The knight of blood and iron...?” Javier’s eyebrow arched a little.

“Yes.”

“Who is that?”

Well, who else? You, the main protagonist in the novel.

Instead of replying, Lloyd smiled. And he recalled the story in the novel.

It probably was around the time Lloyd dies in the novel and when Javier leaves the fiefdom.

It must have been around then. At the time, Javier was a wanted man.

It happens right after the baron and baroness die. At their funeral, Javier slays the two loan sharks.

It was only some time after the loan sharks' corruption was revealed that he was found to have been loyal. He was cleared of all the charges. At least at the point when Lloyd died in the story, Javier was a wanted man. He was one even while he dug a grave for Lloyd. The guards barged into the cemetery and threw themselves at him to arrest him.

Of course, Javier overpowered them without causing any harm. To avoid the search group, Javier hid in the eastern mountain range. That hiding place was no other than Lake Kapua.

And I think he says something like this to himself, "What a relief it is that King Stoma is currently in hibernation."

Proving his words right, Javier was able to safely hide in the lake for a month. He eventually lost the chasing guards and crossed over the range.

"Anyway, Lake Kapua is the best intake station. Thanks to the permanent snow in the peak that melts regularly, the water level is consistent all throughout the year. The water is clear, and the turbidity is low. Plus, the foundation to install water pipes from the lake to the fiefdom is stable and straight."

Lloyd was now taking a break and sitting on the edge of a rock. Wiping his sweat off, Lloyd looked around the land. Just like he had said, the mountain slope was mostly straight and easy except for one place. Javier pointed at the very area. A look of doubt played across his face.

"Then how do you plan on putting the pipe in that area?"

The silver-haired knight pointed to a valley that seemed to sharply disconnect the terrain from the others. The valley was about two hundred and sixty feet wide, sitting between two towering cliffs that faced each other. Lloyd motioned with his fingers and drew the route of the water pipe, so it went over one cliff to the next.

Javier grew curious. *He's going to make the water pipe go over the valley? How?* He couldn't wrap his head around this and questioned if it was even possible. However, he didn't doubt Lloyd. After all, his young master had shown extremely mysterious and amazing methods of construction multiple times. From the heated flooring system, paved road, mine, seokbinggo, and the Maritz land. Lloyd produced unbelievable results. So this time as well...

"Do you have anything planned?"

Javier thought that he probably had and his assumption was proven right when he heard the following answer from his young master, the former hooligan, Lloyd.

"Of course. I'm going to build an aqueduct."

"What is an aqueduct?"

"There's something like that. The siphon effect isn't going to be enough to pull the water from here across the valley anyway."

The corners of Lloyd's lips rose slightly. The method to overcome the mountain valley's geography and stably place the water pipes over the stream...It was no other than the arched Roman aqueduct, the gift and legacy of the brilliant Roman Empire that once existed on earth.

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Chapter 54: The Fiefdom’s First Accomplishment (1)

The Roman-style aqueduct. It was a major civil engineering feat that transcended the period of the Roman Empire. The Aqua Appia was constructed in 312 BC. The Anio Vetus was completed in 272 BC and Aqua Marcia was finished in 144 BC. Aside from these, countless aqueducts connected Rome to the outskirts of the city. Some stretched as near as dozens of miles, while some drew water from areas as far as over sixty-two miles away. Thanks to them, almost a million Roman citizens enjoyed a stable water supply regardless of the season.

What’s more, is that most of them remain today. They’re still being used to supply water even now.

Just then, a memory of when Lloyd was a college student suddenly came to mind.

Lloyd recalled when he was active in his club that investigated and researched traditional architecture. The investigation wasn’t exclusive to those in the country. It explored those that existed across the world as well. One time, he had once looked into the Roman-style aqueduct.

W*hat surprised me the most was Aqua Julia.*

It was like any other aqueducts that were built before the common era. However, it was functioning properly even to this day. He was utterly shocked when he found out that such an ancient device still provided water to the Piazza di Spagna and Trevi Fountain of Rome and other older city districts.

“So, in short, a well-built aqueduct can easily last decades and prevent many generations from worrying about water. But, of course, it needs to be regularly maintained,” Lloyd spoke as he pushed away his memories.

His hands moved to point twice at the cliffs that were standing like a folding screen.

“So if I am to put the aqueduct here, it’s best if I lay it from there to there. The ground is good enough. The elevation is low. Plus, earthquakes aren’t a problem in this place.”

Javier, who was listening to Lloyd, didn’t say anything.

“Also, it looks like I can acquire the limestones needed to build the aqueduct around here. Look, do you see the bedrock slightly protruding over there? Those are all limestones.”

“We can use the wood from a nearby forest to build the foundation of the arches. This place isn’t too far from the fiefdom, so the workers will hardly have any difficulty coming up here. Don’t you think so?”

“Hey, why are you so quiet?”

“Master Lloyd...”

It was only when Lloyd called him out that Javier spoke.

“Where did you learn all this?”

“All this? What do you mean? Construction?”

“Yes.”

Javier continued to talk.

“I cannot understand it. From what I remember, you were never such a capable person,” he said.

“Dang. Really?”

Lloyd stared at Javier blankly.

“You’re telling me straight to my face that I’m incapable?”

“I am speaking the truth.”

Javier replied adamantly without an inch of concession. He continued to hit Lloyd with unreserved candor.

“You were lazy, indolent, lax, and slow to learn. Oh, there was one thing that you liked learning, actually.”

“Could it be math?”

Lloyd asked, expectant.

“Not at all. Who do you think you are?”

“A pure talent envied by the heavens.”

Javier grimaced.

“Hey, there’s no need to put on such a disgusted face.”

“You were only interested in playing around. You gave yourself to drinking and boisterous talks. Your attention was spent on nothing but playing drinking games I had never heard of with a drunkenly flushed face.”

Javier spoke as he sighed.

“So I cannot wrap my head around you these days. This knowledge. Where in the world did you learn all of it?”

Javier’s expression and gaze were serious without any hint of a joke. They were laden with genuine doubt. To be honest, Lloyd understood the confusion Javier was feeling at the moment.

The Young Master Lloyd Javier knew would have been a good-for-nothing alcoholic.

However, the man started to demonstrate incredible knowledge he could never even fathom. It wasn’t as if the young master ever had a phase of fervent studying either. *I’m sure Javier will think that something’s going on with me, something he doesn’t know.* Lloyd sighed at length, and he put on a serious expression.

“Are you asking where I learned all this?”

“Yes.”

“Are you going to believe me if I tell you?” asked Lloyd.

“I will judge after I hear your answer.”

“Hmm, is that so...”

Lloyd sucked in his breath. With a serious expression, he then said, “University of Korea.”

“Excuse me?”

Javier arched one of his brows.

“I told you before. University of Korea. Actually, the place appears in my dream every day. I don’t know why. In my dream, I am a student there learning various things, and I simply make use of that knowledge.”

“What kind of...”

“I’m not lying. That’s why my head is filled with new knowledge every morning I wake up. The constructions I have finished, the techniques, and the things I recite in your lullaby... That was how I obtained all of it. So what now? Can you believe me now?”

“Not really. I cannot believe you.”

“Right? I was just lying.”

Javier stared at Lloyd without uttering a word.

“It’s the truth if you believe it. It’s a lie if you don’t. That’s the way it is, isn’t it?”

“In other words, you don’t have the intention to give me a proper answer.”

“Well, maybe it’s because you are not going to believe me anyway.”

Lloyd chuckled and shrugged. At times like these, Lloyd thought to himself, he needed to put on a thick skin and come up with an adequately brazen lie. He also had a backup plan in case he needed to escape the conversation. Perhaps that was the reason why Javier shook his head.

“Truly, Master Lloyd. I feel like I never really know you.”

Just then...

[Javier Asrahan thought that your response was perfunctory.]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has decreased by one point.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: -nine]

[Even though your relationship with the major character has worsened a little bit, your RP remains unchanged and will not be forfeited.]

[Current RP: 1337]

Dammit. What is this?

The message that popped up in front of him. Lloyd read down the message with a dumbstruck expression. He had made up the story about learning everything by going to university in his dreams on the fly. He didn’t think much of it. The response was also meant to confuse Javier. So, he didn’t have an iota of expectation that Javier would buy it. He was right to expect so because Javier didn’t trust him anyway.

It must have offended Javier in some way. Lloyd, however, gave no thought to Javier’s petty reaction. His mind was more focused on the RP that remained unchanged even as his likeability with Javier lowered. *Hahaha. This is amazing!* Lloyd found himself smiling, the corners of his lips reaching his ears.

RP also called Relationship Points was the greatest source of strength for Lloyd. It was so when he fought a duel with Sir Neumann, the former

senior knight of the fiefdom, and when he got trapped in the ant cave. Even when he picked summon partners for construction, his RP always acted like a secret weapon that equipped him with the most appropriate power at the most critical moments. So, in truth, Lloyd was slightly concerned about it. He predicted that earning RP would gradually become more difficult down the road. *That's because there's a limit to how much one can be liked by others.* A case in point was the baron, baroness, and Javier. At first, his likeability with them was negative. So even a slight positive change of attitude got Lloyd to receive a message saying his likeability increased.

But that changed when he started to become liked by everyone. *Lately, it's been becoming harder to acquire likeability from people.* Humans surprisingly got used to things fast.

Even an initially shocking event would become boring with repetition. It was the same case when you were interested in someone. If you had one good interaction, you needed to do better afterward. Otherwise, people became unimpressed as they were tyrannized by familiarity. This psychological trap was the very thing Lloyd was worried about.

Right now, I'm not feeling it because the likeability is not that high. But once it starts to get really high, I'll have to put in a lot of effort to gain even one likeability point.

Of course, he could always expand his social circle and build friendships with more people.

That, however, was tiresome work. *And it's not like I'm super popular or cool.* Besides, he couldn't be liked by everyone forever. This meant only one thing: earning RP, his ultimate weapon, was bound to be difficult as time passed by. This concern had been lingering around in his head for a while, but the message that just popped in front of him cleared all the worries and burdens off his heart. *I don't lose my RP even if my likeability lowers!* This was an excellent thing. When his likeability with a particular individual became too high, and it became a challenge to improve their relationship to gain points...

I can intentionally make the person not like me, only to improve the relationship later on to increase my likeability.

Lloyd swallowed. *Will it work?* Lloyd turned and looked at Javier. He decided to test his luck.

“Hey, are you upset because I didn’t answer your question properly?”

“No,” replied Javier.

“Hmm. Yes, you are. You are upset.”

“I doubt it. I didn’t expect much from you in the first place.”

Could it be the decreased likeability? For some reason, Lloyd sensed a slight change in Javier’s response. It was colder than usual. However, Lloyd didn’t care. He simply decided to act thick-skinned. *I am going to test it out regardless of how you respond.* With that thought, Lloyd licked his lips.

“You didn’t expect it in the first place...Hmm. That’s too bad. I was actually expecting a lot from you.”

“Excuse me...?”

Javier turned and gazed back at him, his eyes filled with confusion. Lloyd then locked eyes with him and enduring the embarrassment that was welling up from deep inside his organs, he said, “Although I never said it out loud, I am relieved and thankful that you always help me out.”

“Hey?”

Javier didn’t respond. He simply gazed at him.

“Why are you quiet again?”

“Haa. Nothing, Young Master. I just suddenly got goosebumps all over my body.”

“Were my words that bad...?”

“Yes,” Javier said flatly.

“Wow.”

Javier nodded without a second of hesitation.

“For a second, I thought you lost your mind, were struck by a great blow, took some weird drug behind my back, or got bitten by a rabid dog.”

“Hey,” Lloyd called.

“I’ll just assume it was a slip of your tongue.”

“Tsk. Let’s just say it was.”

“What do you mean by ‘Let’s just say it was’?”

“It obviously means that I misspoke, you bastard.”

“Whew. What a relief.”

Javier ran his hand over his chest with a sincere expression on his face. At the same time, a new message popped in front of Lloyd. *Ding Dong.*

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by one point.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: -eight]

[You have earned 18 RP by improving relationships with the main character.]

[Current RP: 1355]

Nice, I guess?

Lloyd clenched his fists, hiding them from Javier. The experiment ended with success. His theory worked. *Since it works this way, I won’t have to worry about earning RP anymore.* Lloyd simply needed to be a jerk and then act nice afterward or he could act heartlessly and comfort them again.

By manipulating people’s feelings over and over again, he would be able to earn RP in a stable manner. An eerie smile escaped from Lloyd as he thought about it.

“Fine, it is such a relief, eighteen-RP man”

“Excuse me?” Javier stopped in his tracks. “Did you just curse at me?”

“No, not at all. Never.”

“It sounded like you did.”

“Come on. You must have heard me wrong. Anyway, let’s get moving. We have a lot to do.”

“Yes...”

Lloyd dusted off his pants and got up. Javier, who still wore a suspicious look on his face, rose and followed him. A mountain of work awaited them and Lloyd wasn’t the type of person to procrastinate.

“Let’s set the route again as we go down over there.”

There was a place to bury the water supply pipes and a place to create stable routes. Lloyd had considered all of these factors. The Underground Scanning, Floorplan Marking (3D), and even the Simulation Mode. Lloyd’s gaze grew now more serious than ever as he used all of these optional skills at the same time. Javier’s gaze toward Lloyd became more perplexed as he protected his young master. The young master he served felt more complicated the more he stayed around and learned about him. Just like that, the first day of surveying for the water supply construction passed by.

***

The surveying continued a few days later. Thanks to his hard work, Lloyd was able to finalize the best route for installing the water supply pipes from Lake Kapua, which sat in the middle of the eastern mountain range, to the fiefdom. Not only that, Lloyd spent time designing almost every night,

using the Floorplan Marking (three dimensional) and Simulation Mode skill.

Thanks to these skills, I can use a hologram to see the final design on the actual land and run a simulation test.

In real life, when the final construction output was actualized on land, the results were often different from the floor plans. No, the reality of it was there were subtle differences between the design and output the vast majority of the time.

But I'm different.

It was thanks to his two optional design skills that Lloyd could test his design models as many times as he wanted through a simulation. He could even set several physical conditions, such as landslides and earthquakes, to figure out how much the pipes could hold out. He could perform all sorts of experiments and evaluate their results. It was only after multiple all-nighters and running dozens of experiments and calculations that Lloyd became convinced.

"This will be enough."

The Frontera barony that sat in the remote corner of the eastern region of the kingdom… That worthless fiefdom was close to making history with the first water supply system of the Lorasia Continent.

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Chapter 55: The Fiefdom’s First Accomplishment (2)

“Dig, carpet, cut, transport back, polish, and bury. These are your tasks starting today.”

In the deep part of the mountain spring, Lloyd stood on top of a small rock. His speech began amid the chirpings of the mountain birds. The human soldiers in the civil engineering group and muscular orc miners gazed at Lloyd. Lloyd continued his work briefing which was disguised as a speech.

“As every one of you would know, we are not in a safe place. We’re up in the eastern range. So what should we watch out for?”

“The wild animals!”

“The monsters!”

The soldiers and orcs yelled, trying to deafen one another. The corners of Lloyd’s lips pulled up in satisfaction.

“Yes, everyone is right. You’re correct. Wild animals and monsters may appear. So make sure to move in groups. Each group will be composed of twenty members, ten humans, and ten orcs. I believe you remember which group you belong to, right?”

“Yes!”

“Yes, oink!”

“Great,” said Lloyd. “Let’s check the roles assigned to you then. Groups one through six, each composed of twenty members mixed with humans and orcs. What’s your job?”

“To cut the giant bamboo and prune them out!”

“Okay. What about groups seven, eight, and nine?”

“We will transfer the smoothened giant bamboo to the site where the pipes will be installed!”

“Then what about groups ten, eleven, and twelve?”

“We repair the site where the pipes will be laid!”

Lloyd asked, and the soldiers answered. The Q&A session went by without a hitch. Lloyd’s smile deepened as he looked at them.

I’ve raised them well.

Just then, Lloyd remembered the first time he had mobilized the soldiers in the fiefdom to transfer red clay for the heated flooring system construction project. At that time, they were essentially a civil militia made up of ordinary soldiers, average young men you could see in any neighborhood.

But now, things have completely changed. *At this rate, I can throw them into construction sites in Korea, and they’ll adjust quickly.* The commonplace youthful civil militia was long gone. Their white complexions had completely changed, and now, everyone was tanned under the sun. A slight furrow wrinkle sat in between their brows, which was a result of habitual frowning from the sun’s bright glare. A slight mark of dignity could be noticed in their thick and rough mustache. Their clothes had changed as well as their work clothes were ragged but special. Each had various shapes embroidered on their left chest. One was a burned rock, which symbolized the ondol, or the heated flooring system. Another showed a flat surface, signifying the paved road. There was also an embroidery of a deep pit that symbolized the coal mine and a rectangular rock that represented the seokbinggo.

The majority of them carried embankment embroidery, a symbol for the reclaimed Maritz Wetland.

Every single symbol was proof of participation in various construction projects. It was also a form of medal that stirred pride in each soldier. *Plus, their stamina has gotten really great.*

They weren’t muscular and buff the way the gym rats were.

But when it came to strength, Lloyd could ascertain that they were stronger than any other fiefdom’s soldiers. That was because they spent all day moving bricks, soil, and other construction materials. Hammering, sawing, and shoveling were basic construction tasks. The hard labor that came with each task gifted them with tenacious and godly muscles. In other words, they had grown to become seasoned workers who could easily be hired as supervisors on any construction site out there with just a small adjustment period.

“But don’t ever let your guard down and do something idiotic. It’s always the experienced workers who get hurt first because of their stubborn ways. Am I clear?”

“Yes!”

“Okay, everyone except for Group thirteen made up of only civil engineers. Get to work with a shout!”

“Woah!!!”

There were a total of twelve groups. One hundred and twenty civil engineer soldiers and one hundred and twenty orcs held up saws, axes, and various other tools. Each rushed in order toward their respective places. The first six groups headed toward the nearby woods. That was where a huge forest of giant bamboo, each one wider than the body of an orc warrior, was located. The soldiers and miners became one, and their tools glinted against the sunlight that shone above the giant bamboo forest.

“Let’s start chopping from here!”

“I love using the ax, oink!”

“It’s good exercise, oink!”

The human soldiers charged forward with their hand saws. The orc miners swung their stupidly large ax with one hand. The huge stalks of innocent

bamboo were cut down by a storm of loggers. At the same time, the groups beside the loggers smoothened and pruned the chopped bamboo. They cut the stalks in unified lengths and smoothened the outside. The same was done to the inside. The smaller soldiers entered the bamboo stalks to sand any rough edges and drill holes inside. Once the cutting and smoothing were finished, the giant bamboo was shaped into pipes of equal lengths. After that process was over as well, groups seven, eight, and nine on standby entered.

“Grab them up. One, two!”

The human soldiers and orc miners teamed up to transport the giant bamboo pipes.

They traveled, walking over rough mountains, creeks, and rocks. Along their way, they shooed away growling wild animals and fought drooling monsters. They delivered countless bamboo pipes to the site where the water supply system would be built and once they arrived, groups ten, eleven, and twelve received the bamboo pipes. There, right on the spot, Bangul and the blacksmiths worked together to add the stiffeners to the pipes.

“Bangul! Hng-!”

Bangul, who had eaten soil in advance, violently shook her chubby tail. Her bell attached to the tip of her tail blared a loud warning. At the same time, she tightened her bottom.

Splaaash!

Hot metal bars of poop got discharged from the area under her uplifted tail. The blacksmiths rushed toward the metal bars. It didn’t matter if they didn’t have a furnace. The bars were hot and soft because they were just made, allowing them to easily process the bars. They looped the metals around the bamboo pipes that groups seven, eight, and nine had delivered. The stiffeners would hold the pipes strong and sturdy against the water pressure that could make them crack or burst otherwise. Meanwhile, the workers in groups ten, eleven, and twelve assisted Ppodong.

“Ppodong! Ppo-do-do-dong!”

A sandstorm appeared wherever Ppodong went and once the storm left the area, a large pit was created in its wake. That was where the bamboo pipes would be installed. Of course, Ppodong hadn’t dug the ground haphazardly.

“Ppodong! Ppo-do-dong!”

Ppdodong dug the areas Lloyd marked on the ground. His digging was precise according to the depths and widths he was told in advance. It was perfectly in line with Lloyd’s design plan. Lloyd had to consider several factors for the foundation, including its earth pressure, surcharge load, vulnerability to earthquakes, water pressure, and surface load. Moreover, Lloyd’s design was also the result of carefully calculating the bearing power and expected subsidence. When Ppodong’s amazing feat left a huge hole in the ground, groups ten, eleven, and twelve followed behind.

“Okay, clean up the ground!”

“Woah, oink!”

The human soldiers and orc miners flattened the surface. They painted on a generous amount of stiffener to prevent any potential flooding or sinking. Once the ground was flattened, they laid out the rocks. Then, they pasted the rocks with a thick layer of limestone-mixed mud. On its very top came the pruned and processed giant bamboo pipes.

They added the paste of limestone-mixed mud around the pipes without missing a single spot. On top of that, the pipes were covered with tightly packed dirt. This method was called the backfill method. With that, they had finished one section of the pipe.

Of course, amid the ongoing construction, everyone strove hard to meet the exact measurements Lloyd had given them. When one section of pipe was over, they moved on to the next section. This process was repeated over and over again. While all this happened, Lloyd commanded group thirteen, which was composed of sixty civil engineer soldiers. He brought them to the lake that sat in the middle of the mountain range. Here, they proceeded

with constructing the aqueduct. The first one to start the construction was Javier.

“Alright, Javier. You know what to do, don’t you?”

“Use the manablast to blow out the areas you marked?”

“Obviously. This isn’t your first time doing this.”

“Were you about to say I should run back after the blast, or else, I would whine in pain under the crushing weight of the crumbling rocks?”

“No, I wasn’t going to,” Lloyd said and looked away.

“Then?”

“If I see you crushed under a rock, I’ll be kind enough to set up a tombstone for you there.”

“I’ll be back...”

Javier then walked off.

It was pure luck that there was a bedrock of limestone that lay bare and plain near the construction site. Javier drew his sword and stood in front of the bedrock. He pointed at the mark Lloyd made.

He wielded his sword, which swung dozens of times in the air at lightning speed. He then contained the explosive power of the mana circle that collided at the same time. Combined it resulted in a precise yet deadly act of destruction. The bedrock, which had been there for hundreds and thousands of years, exploded a dozen times from the inside. The power blast split the hard bedrock. The bedrock was blasted into dice-sized chunks of rocks. Masons and soldiers held out their chisels and hammers and rushed toward the rocks.

“Okay, don’t space out now! Make sure you don’t get any shards of rocks into your eyes!”

They split, broke, and divided the rocks by following the marks Lloyd drew for them. The tranquil valley suddenly turned into a limestone bonanza. While the masons and soldiers were at work, the carpenters were busy as well with the aqueduct floor plan Lloyd had given them. Their mission was to build an arch support frame according to the plan, which was where the stone arches would be built.

Everyone wielded their tools strongly and powerfully. The wooden support frame was finished. In the shape of a rainbow, this firm support frame was topped with a block of limestone. Once the blocks fit perfectly, they created an arch. After that, the support frame was dismantled and reassembled right beside it. Another limestone block was added on top of the support frame again. Thus, another arch was constructed.

As such, the cycle of construction continued to repeat. On one side, the workers logged giant bamboo, made them into pipes, and laid them under the ground. At the valley, an arch-shaped aqueduct three floors tall, with a height of fifty-five feet, and twenty-nine feet in length, was erected. Each time a bead of sweat streaked down on workers' faces, another pipe was connected one after another. Each time they shouted, the height of the stacked limestone block got taller. About two months later, under the drizzling rain of late fall, the two tasks finally merged into one masterpiece.

"Okay, be careful! Slowly! Make sure you fasten it tightly!"

Lloyd stepped forward, his tool belt wrapped around his waist. He climbed up the finished aqueduct himself and commanded the installation of the last bamboo pipe. It was fifty-five feet from the ground. The peak of the narrow aqueduct was slippery due to rainwater.

It was the perfect position to accidentally fall off. That was the reason why Lloyd was doing the most dangerous task.

I must do this by myself. Otherwise, the atmosphere among the workers will be dampened.

No matter how much Lloyd showered them with bonuses and rewards, the dangers of their work didn't change.

The mood of the construction site would quickly be ruined if he pressured the workers to do dangerous jobs. *They'll calculate whether the money they receive is worth the risk of their job. This will make them decide how much their lives are worth.* That was the natural thought process for those who had dangerous jobs. Lloyd didn't wish for his soldiers to make such decisions. *It's not a good feeling. I know because I thought of it too.* He knew the feeling very well. Truthfully, it was an awful one. Valuing his life based on money made him feel like he was just an object that could be replaced at any time. Once someone felt that way, they became distrustful of construction work. That was the reason why Lloyd led the riskiest part of the construction, which was standing on top of the aqueduct top and leading the process.

But he was with the most reliable individuals among the workers.

"Okay, carefully take a step here. Javier. Sir Bayern. Arosh. Count now."

"One."

"Two."

"Three, oink!"

"Let go!"

Lloyd, Javier, Sir Bayern, and Arosh moved as one group. They lifted the bamboo pipe above the aqueduct. They moved it, let it down, and connected it. At last, the last pipe was laid and linked. However, that wasn't the end of the job. *The final verification is still left.* Laying the pipes wasn't the end. There had to be a final check-up to determine whether the water flowed correctly.

So Lloyd climbed up to Lake Kapua and arrived at the intake station that would direct the lake water to flow through the pipes. He turned the valve affixed to the intake gate. *Creak!* The steel intake gate opened up. The lake water passed the muck frame made out of bamboo to flow into the pipe. Lloyd's gaze acutely studied the water flow. *The water is moving just right. It's just as I had designed it.* Lloyd designed that the velocity of water

flowing through the pipes from Lake Kapua's intake station to the fiefdom to fall between 0.5 to three m/s. If the velocity was slower than that, sand and other sediments would block and clog the pipes. However, if the velocity was too fast, the water pressure would eventually damage the pipes.

But at the current velocity I'm seeing… I won't have to worry about it for the time being.

Lloyd continued to observe the flow of water and he waited. What did he wait for? He was waiting for a hopeful message from the foot of the mountain where his fiefdom was at.

Sometime later…*I should be hearing from them right about now...*It was when Lloyd was nervously biting his bottom lip.

A series of shouts started echoing up from the foot of the hill. It was the shouts from the line of soldiers who were stationed in the interval from the fiefdom to the intake station. They were shouting the message that started from the fiefdom, relaying it to the one next. Their shouts slowly traveled up to Lloyd.

At last, a full message arrived to Lloyd.

"The fiefdom's purification plant has water! There is no leakage in between!"

Everyone cheered aloud. It was the end of the long construction. Everyone clenched their fists as they finally saw the results of their hard work. They exchanged gazes of satisfaction with those beside them. Just like that, the construction site erupted with joy and excitement.

Everyone except for one: Lloyd.

"Whew! Done. Let's go collect the construction fee now."

Lloyd smirked and casually touched Javier on the shoulder like he was brazenly asking to go to a local arcade or for a complimentary drink at a

restaurant. Thus, Javier was left in confusion.

Construction fee? Collect what?

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Chapter 56: The Devil's Contract (1)

"Let's go collect the construction fee now."

"Excuse me?"

Javier stared at Lloyd, feeling bemused.

Construction fee? Collect what?

Javier didn't know the nonsense he was hearing out of the blue.

"I am not sure what you mean."

He couldn't wrap his head around this. Instead of answering, his young master simply scoffed.

"Don't you know what a construction fee is?"

"Of course, I know."

Construction fee referred to the money used for construction. It referred to the overall expenditure for the construction, including the cost of the supplies, equipment, labor, and facility management. So Javier thought it was strange.

"Who will you collect it from?"

He tried to guess from whom the money would be collected but no one in particular came to his mind. The water supply system wasn't commissioned by a paying customer. It was started voluntarily to overcome the river contamination crisis and establish a safe system for acquiring clean water. Just like how people replaced old and shabby windows and repaired weakened roofs, this construction was initiated by necessity in the fiefdom. Therefore, there was no party to milk money out of. Javier slightly furrowed his brows.

“Are you planning on demanding a construction fee from Viscount Lacona as a form of compensation?” asked Javier, tossing the question that seemed likely.

“Hm? No, I’m not,” said Lloyd.

His young master then curled one corner of his lips and continued, which only confused Javier all the more.

“Compensation? How could you say that? Do you think we’ll be able to make ends meet with that?”

“Excuse me...?”

“Something better and more abundant than that awaits us. So just be quiet and follow me. Hey, you.”

Lloyd scoffed and then called Sir Bayern, who was cleaning up the construction site.

“You called for me, Master Lloyd?” answered Sir Bayern.

“Yes, I did. I need you to run some errands.”

“I’m at your service.”

“Okay, let’s see. First, Sir Asrahan and I will be off somewhere. So please take charge of wrapping everything up. Make sure all the workers and tools are in the right place. Get rid of all the food waste. We want this place cleaned up. Otherwise, it’s going to attract wild animals around here.”

“I understand,” replied Sir Bayern.

“Does that mean you will be missing the construction completion ceremony?”

“Why would you say that? Of course, I’ll be at the town celebration.”

“Then...”

“Tell the baron that I’ll be back soon. I already told him where I’m going in advance.”

“Yes.”

“Oh, and one more thing,” said Lloyd, turning back to Sir Bayern.

“Yes?”

“Tell him not to pop the champagne without me.”

“I will keep that in mind. Have a safe trip.”

Sir Bayern bowed and paid his respect. Accepting his farewell, Lloyd turned to Javier and said, “Alright, let’s go.”

Javier followed behind Lloyd without saying anything. He still had his grimace on his face even when he descended from the mountain. *What in the world is he up to?* The direction Lloyd was heading most definitely didn’t lead to the fiefdom. *This path takes us to the Lacona viscounty.* He was familiar as he had taken this road a few times and so, greater curiosity and nervousness washed over Javier.

“Master Lloyd,” Javier spoke as he walked behind Lloyd.

Lloyd didn’t stop despite his name being called. He replied as he kept walking down.

“Yeah, I’m listening.”

“Are you really going to the viscounty?”

“Yes,” Lloyd replied.

“Are you by any chance planning on meeting Viscount Lacona?”

“Yes.”

“What do you plan to do once you meet him?”

“Why? Are you worried that I’ll make a scene?”

Indeed, that was his greatest concern.

Javier collected his thoughts for some seconds before speaking.

“To be honest, I understand you, Master Lloyd.”

“Oh? Do you understand me? That’s rare. We’re off to a good start. Continue.”

“Yes, Viscount Lacona is obviously in the wrong for dumping the toxic water in the river. Blackmailing the lord afterward was extremely petty and unscrupulous of him. His actions led us to spend an unexpected amount of funds and labor on building the water supply system. That is the truth, without a doubt. However...”

Javier paused for a second before continuing.

“It is my personal opinion that sometimes we must hold back and be content with the fact that we avoided such harm.”

“Hmm, are you suggesting that I must be a man of great patience?” asked Lloyd.

“No. I am suggesting that you make an objective and realistic judgment.”

“Objective? Realistic?”

“Yes.”

Javier’s voice sounded more forceful this time. Staring at Lloyd's back still ahead of him, Javier said, "Yes, we can meet Viscount Lacona once we arrive at the viscounty and we can raise issues with the dirty tricks he pulled. What would we gain by doing so?”

Lloyd kept listening in silence.

“Nitpicking our opponent’s wrongdoings and raising issues with it...Thinking objectively for a second would prove that it is worthless, and we would gain nothing except emotional satisfaction. What’s more, it would stir unnecessary disputes.”

“Right, now that you mention it, it does seem like that,” replied Lloyd.

“So, are you willing to change your mind now?”

“No,” Lloyd flatly answered and continued to walk ahead.

Javier caught a slight tremble in Lloyd’s shoulders. He must have laughed for a moment.

Surely, when Lloyd replied back, Javier noticed a wry smile on Lloyd.

“Hey, Javier Asrahan. Do you think that I’ll push ahead with something that doesn’t benefit me?”

“Excuse me?”

Javier’s voice contained a little bit of surprise.

“Tell me, do I look like that person?”

“May I be frank?”

“Yes.”

“The Master Lloyd I know is a petty, vindictive, and small-minded tight-ass who never lets himself be in a position of loss,” declared Javier.

“Wow.”

“That is why I believe that this way of blowing off your steam is not like you. Please behave like you usually do.”

“Ha!” huffed Lloyd.

“Is that what it looks like to you? Blowing off some steam?”

“Then...”

“Just be quiet and watch me.”

Javier clamped his mouth shut. He had somewhat zealously given the advice to dissuade his young master. However, Lloyd didn’t take it. Javier thought that saying something more now would simply be crossing the line. *I guess he’s going to let his emotion take control and throw it against the wind.* They would soon arrive at the viscounty.

Even if Lloyd sat down with the viscount, what would he gain? Javier wondered to himself.

What good was there even if he eloquently went over the viscount’s wrongdoings one after another? Be it the compensation or construction fee… The viscount would never give a penny to them. After all, the viscount had no reason, cause, or necessity to do that.

Thinking such, the silver-haired knight followed Lloyd without a word. About three or four hours later, they got down from the mountain. No conversation took place in between.

They finally arrived at the viscounty. A savory smell permeated the village. It was the smell of dinner getting ready. Lloyd and Javier walked past two villages as they indulged in the savory smell of the food and arrived in front of the viscount manor.

“Stop.”

“The visitors must reveal their status and name.”

The two gatekeepers stopped them at the gate but Javier didn’t have the chance to say anything because Lloyd spoke first.

“I am Lloyd Frontera, the official successor to the Frontera barony, the neighboring fiefdom of yours. Relay back that I am here to meet Viscount Lacona.”

“Is this an official request for an audience with the viscount?” one of them asked.

“Yes.”

Lloyd’s confident tone and attitude softened the soldiers. One of them stayed at the gate to protect it while the other one ran into the manor to relay the message. A short wait ensued.

During this time, Javier internally said, *It’ll get rejected.* A request for an audience with the viscount. It was a reach and much too reckless at the same time. Normally, one would visit a noble after contacting them in advance about the nature of the meeting, and only then would the meeting be permitted after it was properly scheduled. It was rare for anyone to appear in front of the gate out of the blue without any prior message. It was also considered ill-mannered among the nobles. So even if they got rejected, they weren’t in a position to complain. *Actually, it’s obvious that he’ll get rejected.…*

“The viscount has agreed to meet you.”

What? Javier’s eyebrow twitched. *Why did he not reject it?* Of course, it was good that the viscount didn’t. It was just beyond him how the request for an unplanned meeting didn’t fall through. It didn’t make any sense but that very senseless event was taking place at the moment. What was more, the person who came to escort him and Lloyd looked like the viscounty administrator. *How? Why?* Countless questions floated in Javier's head as they entered the manor even after the administrator guided them to walk through the hallway.

The incomprehensible situation continued even after that. They were now at the end of a hallway.

“The eldest son of the Frontera family, Lloyd Frontera, has arrived,” reported the administrator in front of the reception room.

“Let him in.”

And the voice that came from inside belonged to the viscount.

Javier's eyebrow twitched once more. *The viscount is already in the room waiting for us?*

This was another incomprehensible turn of events. *We are uninvited guests who came without any warning. Yet, the viscount not only accepted our request but is waiting for us in the reception room?* The door opened, and the viscount was sitting in a chair inside as he stroked his goatee. Something was off about the viscount's gaze and attitude toward them.

"Haha. It's been a while, my friends."

"Nice to meet you."

"Come and take your seats."

"Thank you."

The viscount was glowering their way, at Lloyd to be exact, with a murderous look in his eyes.

His gaze resembled a spiteful viper but it looked like the viscount was forcibly repressing his venomous spite for some reason. On the other hand, Lloyd was...

"I do not know how to thank you for welcoming us with open arms."

Javier was terribly flustered whereas Lloyd was relaxed and in control. He was full of confidence and so, Javier was thrown into great confusion. *What on earth is happening right now?* This situation was poles apart from what he had in mind. *Surely, Master Lloyd should be angry, and Viscount Lacona should be relaxed in this situation.* That was only natural. Lloyd was supposed to be here to complain about what Viscount Lacona had done. Viscount Lacona was supposed to jeer at Lloyd for doing so.

The tables were turned for some strange reason. Lloyd was brimming with confidence.

Viscount Lacona was fuming with anger. This was truly and sincerely strange. *What is happening?* Something was going on. Something he didn't know.

Thinking that to himself, Javier's eyes sharpened, and he tried to understand the connection between the two men. While Javier was deep in thought, Lloyd and Viscount Lacona continued their strange meeting.

"By the way, Viscount Lacona," called Lloyd.

"What is it?"

"Do you have any concerns these days?"

"There is nothing of the sort," replied the viscount.

"Are you sure?" pressed Lloyd once more.

"Of course."

"Doesn't the whole world grow black, or don't you feel terribly nauseated when you wake up in the morning?"

"Not at all. There is nothing wrong with my health."

"Hmm...What I just asked are the symptoms of extreme mental stress."

"What is there for me to be concerned about?" The viscount shifted in his seat.

"Are you sure? Really?"

"Why are you harping on something so obvious?" The viscount's eyes narrowed.

"Can I not ask?"

The viscount glared at Lloyd. Lloyd shrugged.

“I already know everything. Be honest with me.”

“Be honest? With what?”

“Aren’t you desperate now, regardless?”

“I don’t know what you mean,” the viscount said.

“Haha. There is something urgent that's desperately in need of a solution, but you are absolutely in the dark about its cause. But at the back of your mind, you have someone you suspect. That’s why you are here to meet me. Am I wrong?” said Lloyd in a casual tone.

“What do you…”

“I am saying that you want to confirm something with me.”

The viscount shut his mouth. The corners of Lloyd’s lips rolled upward.

“That is the thing with concerns. They are hard to share with others but drive you mad with frustration if you keep them to yourself. Am I wrong?”

“I am never…”

“Come on. Lay down your shitty pride.”

“I do not know what it is that you want to say,” denied the viscount.

“What I’m about to tell you will sound very familiar to you.”

The viscount didn’t reply.

“I know that your heart drops each time I keep speaking like this because you have a feeling that your agonizing fears will be confirmed. Now you know for sure that I am the source of the incident that tortures you to this day. Am I wrong?”

Silence.

“Are you still going to not talk?”

Silence again.

“Just accept it now, and give up. Think about it. Your efforts may betray you, but giving up will never fail,” pressed Lloyd.

“What kind of gibberish are you sp...”

“I can’t believe that you’re still trying to keep your pride even at this point. Nothing will be solved like this. It’s time to negotiate. That’s why I’m here to relieve your burden. Think about it. There is no kinder neighbor than me.”

“I never consider you my...”

Cutting in once more, Lloyd said, “Your dye workshop has been going terribly, hasn’t it?”

Lloyd then tossed a harmless question, flashing a smile as he said it. At that moment, Javier saw very clearly. He saw the way the viscount’s face turned red. The way his goatee trembled. How his glare grew bloodshot. Silence. Sometime later, the viscount asked back, growling as he gritted his teeth. “I knew it was you.”

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Chapter 57: The Devil's Contract (2)

The atmosphere in the reception room sank in an instant. The viscount's eyes burned with rage. Lloyd's expression, however, grew more casual as he received such gaze.

"What do you mean by 'I knew it was you'?"

Lloyd shrugged. He tilted his head to the side.

In a brazen manner, he asked, "It looks like you still haven't put down your pride, viscount. You suspected that it was me a long time ago, and your heart must have sunk earlier when you confirmed your suspicion. Yet, you say, 'I knew it was you'? Come on, isn't that reply too contrived?"

"What..."

"I like the expression on your face right now. Let's keep it that way," ordered Lloyd.

Lloyd raised his hand as he buried into the sofa, and with a slight gesture, he flicked his fingers.

"Look now. You were already suspicious of me, as I thought. How nice would it have been if you just came clean when we first met?"

"So... you are indeed the one who messed up my dye workshop?"

"Yes, I did it," admitted Lloyd.

"What have you done?"

"Are you asking about the method?"

"Haa. Of course."

The viscount heaved a heavy sigh as he glared at Lloyd. He was curious for a good reason.

The dye workshop. The mere thought of it brought a sigh out of the viscount.

My most precious dye workshop…

The workshop was the viscount's golden goose. Laconata was a fabric that was specially processed with the Ladona berry extracts. The Laconata fabric was extremely beautiful. It was luxurious and multicolored, to say the least. Its fine and deep gloss was indescribably unique. Other fiefdoms could never copy the product even if they used the same Ladona berry. The unique color could only be obtained when the Ladona berry was harvested from the western area of the eastern mountain range. One could try to plant the berries elsewhere, but the color and gloss would be lost. Not only that, those berries could not be used because of how they changed during the transportation process. The color of the fabric reflected this change as well.

What was more, the viscounty had special knowledge from producing the Laconata for over a hundred years. Thanks to all these factors, the Laconata fabric was considered a valuable specialty that could only be produced in the Lacona viscounty. So, it became the backbone of the Lacona viscounty's economy and livelihood. It was a priceless golden goose but one day, the goose started to act strange. No, it died.

That...was something that didn't make any sense.

One morning about fifty days ago, the supervisor of the dye workshop came to the viscount, and he started begging for his life the moment their eyes met. The supervisor said that he was sorry. That he committed a capital offense. He explained that the Laconata cloth came out strange. Once the cloth was dyed, the color turned out terribly. The distinguishing gloss was completely gone.

At first, I thought the problem wouldn't last more than a day.

The viscount thought that the output for the day was a spoiled batch. He figured that something must have gone wrong with the raw materials, the berries or the cloth went wrong. He had thought so but that wasn't the case. The following day, the day after that, and for one whole month, the

Loconata’s identifying gloss and color did not come back. Instead of the beautiful color, now, it was dull and bland. The fine gloss could not be traced at all. It was just gray and muddy. It was a defective product that wasn’t fit to be sold in the slightest. It had become total trash.

That’s when it started.

The dye workshop was in a state of emergency. So they decided to start anew by disposing of the concentrated juice in the storage and making them from scratch. Even so, the Laconata’s color didn’t return. They tried out changing the fabric in its entirety but the result was the same. There was no gloss Naturally, the merchants who regularly purchased Lacotana turned and went away. Even the customers who had done business with the viscounty for a long while stopped their purchases one by one. What was the viscounty’s reliable source of income for so long was gone.

Even as things spiraled out of control, no one could figure out the reason behind the death of the Laconata’s color and gloss. Regardless of how many attempts the viscount made or how much effort he put in, the reason still remained a mystery.

The viscount flew in rage as the situation drove him mad. He developed bald patches on his head from severe stress. Add to that, his kidney ached every night, and bile rose up his throat. Despite this, all the viscount could do was form fruitless doubts. *Yes, that bastard. Lloyd Frontera. Suspecting him was all that I could do!* Actually, his doubt was purely circumstantial without any actual proof. It was impossible not to doubt the boy. After all, he had unilaterally disposed of the wastewater into the river, greatly damaged the fiefdom, and threatened the baron.

At this point, the biggest grudge holder against him would be the people of the Frontera family and the most likely suspect was Lloyd. *This kid is young but meticulous.* The boy had proved countless times his preparedness and shrewdness. With such character, the boy was absolutely capable of plotting something like this. Lloyd was the person that came to his mind no matter how many times he racked his brain. The mystery, however, was how the boy managed to master such a scheme. That was exactly why he had agreed to grant an unexpected audience with Lloyd. He wanted to

confirm what trick the kid had employed in his dye workshop. The viscount yearned to find out how he did it.

“What in the world did you do to my workshop when you are nothing but a penniless beggar?”

The viscount gritted his teeth and he glared at Lloyd. *Curse? Dark magic?* There were no other explanations other than that. Lloyd chuckled.

“Hmm… First, I would like to say kudos to you for figuring out that I was the cause. Your reasoning power exceeded my expectations. But my, my.”

He shrugged.

“What happened in your dye workshop...Technically speaking, I didn’t do it on purpose.”

“What do you mean?”

He didn’t do it on purpose? What joke is trying to say now?

The viscount’s face grew serious. The corners of Lloyd’s lips pulled further up and at last, Lloyd moved his mouth to reveal what had taken place in the workshop.

“That was collateral damage when we built the aqueduct.”

“Aqueduct?”

“Yes,” Lloyd replied.

“We built it in the valley. Very nicely.”

“What does that have anything to do with my workshop?! Speak properly! Stop beating around the bush like you are mocking me!”

Finally, the viscount flew into a rage. He was seated on the close edge of the sofa, and he leaned forward toward Lloyd. Lloyd instead leaned far back.

“Tsk. You don’t have to be so impatient. Do you, by any chance, know the characteristics of limestone?”

“What...?”

“The limestone is one of the sedimentary rocks composed of calcium carbonate.”

“What are you saying...”

What gibberish is he spewing now?

Lloyd continued to explain, “The bones and shells of clams, reefs, sponges, plankton, and many other organisms are made up of calcium carbonate. And when they die, the compound collects at the bottom of the sea. Over time, they accumulate and harden into one. That’s what limestones are.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Shh. Listen until the end. Anyway, the limestone formed in such a way is quite an excellent construction material. Just like for building the aqueduct we created in the middle range of the mountain. Oh, and the limestone foundation turns the water into limewater.”

“Limewater..?”

“Yes. It sounds grand, but it’s actually simple. The calcium and magnesium ions in the limestone get dissolved in the water, slightly altering the mineral ratio of the water.”

“What does that have anything to do with my dye workshop?”

“It is related in many ways.”

“How so?” The viscount’s eyes widened.

“Because the very water of the valley the aqueduct is located at is upstream of the Prona River, which flows from the viscounty to the barony.”

“What...?” The stoic expression of the viscount turned dazed.

He looked like someone who had received a blow to his head but Lloyd continued to explain, his voice sounding casual and nonchalant.

“Are you starting to get the picture now? We conducted a long series of explosions to build the aqueduct in the valley. We blew up the limestone bedrock buried in the valley slope and extracted and brought them out. Oh, in the process, we used our tools quite often to process and cut the limestone into small pieces. Eventually, that led the valley to be carpeted with a huge amount of limestone crumbs and shards. So many that counting them would be like trying to count grains of sand. Thanks to that...”

The smile that Lloyd had on his face was gradually turning evil.

“The valley water slightly became closer to limewater.”

“Then could it be that the reason the color of the Lacontana’s dye has changed is...”

“Yes. It’s because there was a minute change in the chemical makeup of the Prona River.”

“What...That cannot be...” The color drained from the viscount’s face.

“Of course, you would be completely unaware of it. After all, the change was very small and subtle. You couldn’t have even detected it from drinking the water. And it surely isn’t going to have a big effect on the people and environment.”

Lloyd’s evil smile deepened. It was just what he had said. However, it was difficult to say that the blasting and processing of the limestone in the valley had inundated the valley with other minerals. The impact it had on humans, organisms, and the surrounding environment was menial. It was comparable to the impact bananas had on humans with their potassium and radioactive elements.

The potassium in bananas contains radioactive isotopes, but in order for a human to be exposed to radiation, one needs to consume at least one hundred million bananas a day. The same applies here to how the minerals in the Prona River impact the human body. I don't know. It might take drinking around one hundred million liters of water for someone to die from a mineral overdose.

The limewater hardly affected humans. Of course, it was exclusive to humans and the natural environment.

"But it would be a different case for your dye workshop. I presume you use the river water to make your dye and dispose of it. That's how the wastewater that flows to the fiefdom was made. Am I correct?"

"It is what it is. That's a chemical reaction. Oh, maybe you don't know what chemistry is. Anyway, even a slight change in the river that hardly affects people leaves a great impact on delicate undertakings such as dyeing."

"That's..."

"Aw, what do I do? My heart is about to break. I liked the Laconata cloth. It was pretty."

"But I suppose you can say goodbye to your Laconata forever. The river is going to stay in that state for at least a decade. It's not like you have any other method to draw water from somewhere else. You can try making distilled water to get rid of the lime, but that's still going to change the composition of the water, so Laconata's signature color won't come back regardless."

"I'm going to sue you!" bellowed the viscount at last.

"I will raise this unreasonable matter to the Royal Court!"

"Yes, you go sue me," Lloyd replied greasily.

"If you want, sue me as much as you want. But do you think you will win?"

“What?!”

“Limewater is not a pollutant in the first place and obviously not toxic.”

The viscount was at a loss of words and so Lloyd mercilessly attacked him with the truth.

“And what can we do? We didn’t intentionally disperse the limestones and pieces of rocks into the valley. It happened in the process of developing the place. You do know that this doesn’t satisfy the ‘intentionality of action,’ which the Royal Law considers important, right?”

“Intentionality?”

“Yes, the intentionality of action. It refers to acts committed without a clear intention to harm. Plus, if we dig into the matter, the root cause of all this can be traced to you, viscount.”

“To me?! How?!” yelled Viscount Lacona.

“Well, you unilaterally dumped the toxic wastewater into the Prona River that passes my fiefdom. That’s why we worked hard to build the aqueduct in the valley. In the process of doing so, we had no choice but to blast the limestones for quarrying. And that changed the valley water into limewater, which eventually caused your precious Laconata cloth to be the color of poop.”

“What are you...”

“Do you get it now? Don’t cry.”

“No way. No way...”

The viscount, who was leaning forward as he spoke, helplessly sank into the sofa, his back hitting the chair. He let his body fall limp. With dazed and disappointed eyes, he looked up at the ceiling. At last, the cause of this incident was made plain to the viscount. His eyes already lacked focus. *He got me this time.* It felt as though he got hit by a hammer in the back of his head. However, no method to free himself came to his mind. He strove to

come up with something. His wheels turned, but nothing good was there. *Bring the matter to the Royal Court?* The viscount knew it was useless. *I can't win. He's right. The limewater is not toxic. It's just water. So I can't file a complaint against him. E*ven if he did so, even if he won the case with the blessing of god, the future of his viscounty would still be bleak. *It'd take at least a year until a verdict is reached.* The Laconata cloth would be in the same state as right now.

All of his customers would leave him. He would lose his specialty product and become a beggar.

That devil!

Lloyd was smiling in contentment as he looked at him. The sight of his devilish smile made his skin crawl. The viscount couldn't place a finger on how much of the situation was calculated and planned out in Lloyd's head. The viscount was afraid that the brat would do more damage if he did anything more. It felt like Lloyd already had a plan in mind in case he fought back.

It's surely going to be the case, given it's him.

The tip of his fingers trembled against his will and a sense of defeat enveloped him. Despair swept over him. He wondered if this was what it felt like to be an ant trapped in an ant lion's pit. Someone once advised him to calmly close his eyes when things grew difficult in life. He did, only to feel that the darkness ahead of him was his future.

I can't win. There's no way out.

So, at last, the viscount gave up. He racked his brain for a solution but he came up with nothing. There was only one option left for him.

"I shouldn't have done it."

The viscount bowed his head. With a look of distress on his face, he said, "I will immediately stop throwing the wastewater into the river flowing to

your fiefdom. So I plead with you. Can you please...forgive me just this once?”

“Forgive you?”

Lloyd arched his one eyebrow.

“Yes.”

The viscount lowered his head further down. He fumed with anger internally but there was nothing he could do. Lloyd, on the other hand, tossed the answer the viscount never expected to receive.

“Hmm...But what to do? The limewater river can’t be changed back.”

“What...?”

“You can clean up the pieces of limestones scattered in the valley, but that won’t do anything. The blasting exposed too much of the limestone bedrock.”

“What are you saying...”

“I mean it. Originally, the limestone bedrock was lightly covered with a silicate rock formation, which is a clastic sedimentary rock. To put it simply, there was a layer that blanketed the limestone. However, all of that broke, exposing the limestone in the water. There’s nothing you can do now.”

“What are you saying? Then…”

“It means that the river water will always be like this from here on out.”

The viscount became utterly speechless. He had thought that an apology would bring about some solution. That was the only hope he had left but it was fading away now. Just then, this devil, no, Lloyd Frontera, put on a smile.

“Well, but since you are asking for my forgiveness, I’m going to tell you that it isn’t completely impossible to revive your Laconata.”

“What is it?! How?!”

The viscount spoke hurriedly, grabbing Lloyd in the sleeve.

“Woah. Let go of my sleeve, please.”

“Oh, I am sorry. I was just in a hurry...”

“It’s alright. I understand anyway. Let me make you an offer.”

“An offer?”

“Yes, an offer.”

The viscount nibbled his lips as he looked at Lloyd and he waited. At last, Lloyd opened his mouth.

“This is my offer. Viscount, you consider your dye workshop and Laconata fabric very important, right?”

“Yes.”

“You wish to revive it no matter what, right?”

“Yes, of course.”

“Good. Then...”

Lloyd’s eyes curved in contentment. He then laid out the big plan he had been polishing since two months ago when the wastewater crisis first swept over the barony.

“If you wish to bring back the Laconata cloth and continue your beautiful tradition, use my fiefdom’s water supply. Of course, you’ll have to pay a generous monthly water bill with it.”

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Chapter 58: The Devil's Contract (3)

"Of course, you'll have to pay a generous monthly water bill with it."

The viscount's heart sank heavily but he didn't know why. To be honest, he didn't even understand what "water bill" meant. Despite his ignorance, he still had a bad feeling. Nervousness began to creep from the bottom of his heart the moment he heard the word.

The sense of crisis, that pestering feeling that he's winded up in a bad situation, wriggled inside him. Mustering up the courage, the viscount asked,

"Uhm, I am sorry, but...what is a water bill?"

"Oh, is this your first time hearing it? It is simple. You use the clean water from the water supply, and you pay for its usage in return."

"So, payment for using the water?" the viscount asked.

"You do understand fast," said Lloyd.

"Are you placing a tax on water?"

"Yes."

Lloyd grinned, his smile implying why the viscount was asking such an obvious question.

"From the intake station, the water travels through the clean pipes to arrive at the reservoir of the fiefdom. We provide our clients with a stable supply of the highest quality filtered water. It is so clean and pure that grandfathers can drink it, and grandmothers can wash their faces. And mothers and fathers can make stews, and children can lap around in the water. What do you think? Doesn't your heart jump in excitement at the thought of it?"

The viscount didn’t say a word. Lloyd chuckled. *Yeah. Your heart should definitely jump out.*

Lloyd was confident that the viscount’s heart was racing at sixteenth beat per measure at the concept of taxing water usage. *You messed with the wrong person.* Lloyd’s smile became slightly more vicious.

Just then, the time when he first planned out the water supply came to his mind. It was about the day when he was climbing the eastern range with Javier to survey the site. At first, Lloyd was preoccupied with the thought of overcoming the impending crisis. He comforted himself that he would be able to avoid major damage from the whole crisis if he took this opportunity to come up with a stable water supply system, despite the cost. However, deep down, he was enraged. Creating the water supply was good. It really was. Taking comfort in overcoming the crisis wasn’t enough to satisfy this deep-seated grudge sitting in his heart.

Come hell or high water, I wanted to give this viscount a big, fat middle finger.

The viscount sitting across from him had done terrible things as he demanded the barony to return the Maritz Wetland. He dumped toxic wastewater into the river. When Lloyd raised issues with it, the viscount huffed and acted brazenly. The viscount even blackmailed them. The knight he sent snarled at the baron, saying they would continue dumping toxic wastewater unless half of the Maritz Wetland came back into their possession.

They had no manners and no etiquette. Their actions crossed into being tyrannical.

That’s why I could barely sleep during those times.

Each time he lay down to sleep, gold glittered in front of him. The heated flooring system was continually being constructed and sold to people one by one. Even while he was paying off his interest, he still had some money left in his pocket. That was where the money for the construction came from. Lloyd then stingily saved up what was left of the money.

Thanks to you I had to spend every penny in the end.

Lloyd's gaze toward the viscount was icy. The emotions, which were still raw, surged once again, making his blood boil. Perhaps it was because of this rage that he found himself clenching his fist when he discovered the limestone bedrock in the valley of the mountain range on the day he and Javier went out for surveying. It was because of that boiling emotion that an exclamation, "This is it!" erupted in his heart.

A small glimpse of the limestone bedrock had been exposed and the water was flowing to one side of the wide valley. When Lloyd realized that this water was upstream of the Prona River that flowed down to the viscounty and barony, his head added everything up at lightning speed. He saw his chance at once. The plan was drawn out. It was no longer a simple construction for a water supply system. It was also a revenge plan to get back at the viscount.

That's when it started.

Lloyd reset the nature of the water supply construction. It was no longer for the sole purpose of developing the fiefdom. It quite literally turned into a secret weapon to attack the viscount. That was the reason why Lloyd could remain confident.

"Do not worry. There will never be a shortage of water. Why? It's because, from the moment I prepared to build the water supply system, I designed the size of the water supply pipes and intake station to be large enough to cover your dye workshop."

Yes. Everything was planned.

"And I already looked into the route where the water supply pipes can be installed, so it will travel from my fiefdom to your workshop. The foundation is very stable. And the slope is enough for me to conveniently determine the velocity of the water in the pipe."

"What are you saying...?" asked Viscount Lacona.

“It simply means that the survey and design are all completed. Give me the go-ahead, and we can begin construction first thing tomorrow. If we’re fast, it’ll take about fifteen days before you can start receiving clean water for your workshop.”

A nonchalant smile escaped Lloyd but it was the opposite for the viscount. That flushed and trembling expression on the viscount’s face. How much Lloyd had wanted to see it!

“So think about it wisely and consider your current position, viscount. You do not think it is unreasonable to tax water usage, right?”

“That is...”

“Yeah, I know it’s an unfamiliar term, so you might feel a little repelled by it. But, well, you’ll have to give up on your dye workshop and Laconata cloth if you say no.”

The tips of the viscount’s fingers trembled terribly. Lloyd’s smile widened just as much. Javier, watching the two of them, found himself clenching his fists. *How terrifying.* Javier ran his fingers through his arm to calm the hairs on his arm. Javier was well aware of how much of a twisted man he was and how petty and foul he could be.

But Javier didn’t think he was this evil. *I never imagined he was hiding such a plan.* The possibility never occurred to him when the water supply system was finished and when Lloyd suddenly suggested going and collecting construction fees. Javier was absolutely in the dark that this would happen. He didn’t understand what was happening. It was still the case when he descended from the mountain range with Lloyd and when he visited the viscount’s manor and requested the impossible audience with the viscount.

I’d thought all along that Master Lloyd meant to blow off some steam.

So he tried to stop his young master. He had adamantly dissuaded Lloyd, arguing that what he was about to do wasn’t reasonable and that it was

going to swirl him only into another controversy. *But I was wrong.* Javier admitted his mistake without a fight. He couldn't not admit it.

My young master is seriously...shrewd and cunning to the point of perfection, to the point I pity the viscount I have hated all along.

That was his thoughts on the current situation. He revered his young master but pitied the viscount just as much. To be honest, he didn't hold nice feelings for Viscount Lacona. After all, the man had persecuted his lord.

He felt pity for that very man at the moment. The viscount could not be any more pitiful, sorry, and miserable. Even as Javier was watching the situation unfold, the viscount's fingertips, lips, and brows were shaking terribly. Truly, the viscount felt like he had become an ant in an ant lion's pit.

A sense of dread swept over him. *I'm trapped. There is no way out of this.* Who would have imagined that the bastard was so meticulous? Who would have thought he would be pressured like this? He never imagined this would happen, even in his wildest dreams. No, he didn't even know how Lloyd came up with such a plan. A water supply system to draw clean water from a distance? Furthermore, Lloyd had even calculated beforehand how much water the dye workshop would need!

That brat planned on sucking my blood dry from the very beginning.

The viscount's gaze traveled to Lloyd. This young brat was smiling as he looked at him but now, the viscount no longer thought Lloyd was a reckless youngster. Chills ran down his spine each time he looked at the young man. *I messed with the wrong person.* If he could, the viscount wanted to turn back time to two or three months ago. He wanted to slap himself hard for making the decision to call the workshop supervisor and order him to dump the wastewater into the river. It was too late. There was no way to turn back time and there was only one way to revive his dye workshop.

"I get it."

At last, Viscount Lacona nodded his head in despair. A corner of Lloyd's lips curved upward.

“By I get it, you mean...”

“Your offer. I will take it.”

“My offer to install the water supply in your dye workshop?”

“Yes...”

“You made the right choice, viscount.”

As soon as he finished, Lloyd moved and brought out a rolled paper from his embrace and spread it out on the table. The viscount’s eyes trembled.

“What is it?”

“Well, of course. It’s the water supply contract.”

The viscount was at a loss of words. He wondered what kind of schmuck Lloyd was. Once again, he felt another wave of dread wash over him. He couldn’t believe that Lloyd had come with a contract. It seemed to him that Lloyd came prepared and determined to suck him completely dry down to the marrow of his bones. The viscount’s dejected eyes moved as they read through the contract. It was like he was reading a statement declaring his loss in the war. Just then, his eyes shook visibly once again.

“What is this?”

“What is what?

Lloyd asked.

“Here. This part.”

The viscount pointed at the contract, perturbed. His finger was pointing at the part that mentioned the water bill the viscounty was to give to the Frontera family every month.

“Are you sure you put the right number down here?”

“Why? Do you think you are seeing two more zeros than what you think is correct?”

“Yes...” admitted the viscount.

“It appears that there seems to be a mistake...”

“It is the correct number.” Lloyd’s voice was firm.

“The cost on the contract is correct.”

“What...” the viscount trailed.

“Could it be that you think it’s expensive?”

“Well, of course...”

The viscount trailed off again and went back to reading the contract. An absolutely unreasonable price was marked down as the water bill. *But it’s just water.* The mere act of placing a price on water was flabbergasting enough. But the price itself was so ridiculous that he felt like he was slapped three thousand times across the face. Then, Lloyd started scolding the dazed viscount with an expression of pity.

“Goodness. Do you still think water is free? Even now?”

The viscount stayed silent.

“You thought you could use it all you want because it flows down the course of the river, right? But let me break it to you. It was you who taught our barony the importance of the river water.”

The viscount clamped his mouth shut. The toxic wastewater release he had ordered. His face darkened as he thought about it and Lloyd continued to speak.

“Thanks to you, the entire population in my fiefdom came to a realization that day. We realized that water is not free. It’s a resource that can be

destroyed anytime. At times, it’s also something that can be acquired after paying a cost.”

It was true. The majority of the population in his fiefdom had to roll up their sleeves and work for one sip of clean water or one glass of potable water. Even the children helped move rocks to build the temporary reservoir. The heated flooring system construction was completely put to a halt, and all the civil engineering soldiers climbed the eastern mountain range. They cut giant bamboo sticks and shoveled the earth with sweat dripping down their body to build the aqueduct. It was only after that process that the residents in the barony were able to enjoy clean water again. This bone-crushing lesson was that water was, at times, not free. It was time for Lloyd to teach the viscount that lesson.

“Therefore, I cannot understand in the slightest what you mean. How could you think this is expensive? Think about it. Do you not consider the effort of drawing clean water into this place?”

“Do you think the water pipes can be designed and installed in a zap? It requires a tremendous amount of skill and labor. And what about after it is installed? What about management? Who do you think will manage it?”

“Well, that’s...”

“Yes, me. I do it. The Frontera family will be responsible for it. We must make sure that the pipes are sturdy, and without any leaks. Any floating sediments or dirt needs to be managed in the intake station. At times, the old pipes ought to be replaced. Do you think this is a child’s game? Now, can you still say that the water bill is expensive?”

“That’s...”

“Well, then. If you don’t want it.”

The contract on the table was gone. Lloyd quickly rolled the paper back up, and it was making its way back to his embrace when the viscount moved by reflex.

“Hold on!”

Without realizing what he was doing, the viscount held out his hand and clutched Lloyd’s wrist before the contract left his sight. That was when it dawned on him how desperate he made himself look to Lloyd.

“Ahahaha.”

The viscount laughed in awkwardness. Lloyd plastered a bright smile at the viscount and asked, “Did you change your mind?”

“I think I did.”

“Very good. You are a wise man.”

The rolled-up contract was placed on the table again. Lloyd spoke.

“I will make it short. Sign here, here, and right here. Sign your name on these two copies.”

The viscount held up his pen. His face was laden with distress as he dipped his pen in the ink bottle. He was desperately and keenly aware that he was at an impasse.

With a deep sigh, the viscount signed his name. While he was signing the contracts, elation swept over Lloyd, and his heart started to soar. *It’s over. We’re now completely free from paying the interest to the loan sharks.* Lloyd clenched his fists. His thoughts traveled to the debt the barony owed to the loan sharks. He recalled the devastating amount of interest that needed to be paid every month.

He didn’t need to worry about the interest from now on. The reason was simple. The contract Lloyd had handed to the viscount. The water bill would come in every month.

The bill was the same amount of money as the interest he paid to the loan sharks. In other words, the viscount would be shouldering the interest on behalf of the barony. He had secured an interest-free future. From now on, Lloyd would be able to diligently save money and pay the principal debt!

To be honest, I wanted to engulf the dye workshop of the viscounty or demand them to hand over the technology. The viscount would have never said yes to such an offer.

It went without saying. Such an offer would be rejected and could possibly bring about bigger resistance. *In the worst-case scenario, the viscount may not tap into the Royal Court but to the king and send him the petition himself.* Lloyd had changed the river water's composition and ruined their specialty product. There was a massive difference between wanting a water bill in compensation for reviving the workshop and demanding the dye workshop itself. The former bordered on business and the latter bordered on blackmail.

There's a chance I might get sucked into a scandal if I get greedy. Besides, having the king turn against me would bring greater harm. Politically and realistically, taking this much is enough. Besides, I am stuck with this viscounty as my neighbor.

He was not in a video game, conquering land by warring against his neighboring countries. Using the water bill as an extra large straw into the viscount's bank account and sucking it dry...This was the best and most realistic outcome Lloyd thought he could get from this deal.

"Do I have to sign here?"

The viscount was almost done writing his signature. Once the viscount signed his name on the area he pointed to, the contract would be finalized. As Lloyd had that thought and was about to reply back...

"Please, hold on a second, lord!"

The door of the reception room was roughly slammed open. A man with a rigid face entered.

He shouted, "You cannot pay out a water bill or whatever to that deceitful punk! So please do not sign the unreasonable contract and drag out this unscrupulous man right now, lord!"

The sincere outcry came out in between his thick beard. He wasn’t big but robust in build.

It was Sir Curno, the senior knight of the viscounty.

Pointing at Lloyd’s side, the knight solemnly yelled, “Lloyd Frontera! Do you still think you will be safe even after you treat the lord with such contempt?!”

This was an unexpected entrance, a disturbance to an almost-finished deal. As such, Lloyd sent a warm gaze to Sir Curno. To respond to his words, Lloyd decided to be sincere. So he said, “Yes.”

At the same time, Lloyd thought to himself that he had forgotten how much of a nuisance this man was and that it wasn’t like him to forget about this prick. *And just in time, he waltzes into the room and begs me to deal with him. How nice of him.* Lloyd’s smile deepened with a greater sense of reward and satisfaction as he looked at Sir Curno.

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Chapter 59: The Devil's Contract (4)

How he shows up in the most timely manner is beyond me, but seriously, kudos to this guy. He never fails to impress me.

Lloyd smiled in satisfaction. Sir Curno had just barged into the reception room on time and stopped the viscount from signing the contract. Thanks to his interruption, Lloyd was able to recall one fact he had been forgetting all along.

Ah, that prick has been getting under my skin for a while now.

It probably started when they first met, when the construction for the Maritz Wetland was in full swing. Lloyd recalled the knight's impertinent attitude as he came escorting his viscount. That was just the beginning. He later relayed the viscount's threat to dump toxic wastewater and his rude attitude that showed zero respect for the neighboring lord. Lloyd did not forget a single act of his. He had buried these feelings deep in his heart.

It's only natural. Why would I forget about a grudge?

Lloyd lived by a simple yet powerful principle: to cherish and remember every grand gesture of kindness, yet always stand ready to counter even the smallest acts of misfortune with resilience. Just in time, Sir Curno, the thorn in Lloyd's eyes, appeared in front of him. The knight even managed to bring back all the unpleasant memories of the past. As such, Lloyd had no reason not to welcome him.

"Hey," Lloyd said. He flashed a smile at Sir Curno and even waved his hand.

"What brings you here? Are you here to witness the contract?"

"Ridiculous," Sir Curno retorted, and his gaze toward Lloyd grew solemn.

"I heard everything from outside the door. How you mocked and held my viscount in contempt, Lloyd Frontera."

“You eavesdropped?”

“I heard you,” Sir Curno corrected.

“That’s the same as eavesdropping.”

“Anyway, did you just say that I held your viscount in contempt by coming here? Do you really think that way?”

“Certainly.”

A deep set of wrinkles formed on Sir Curno’s nose.

“You used the Laconata cloth, our fiefdom’s specialty product and biggest source of income, to threaten my lord. Moreover, in order to satisfy your desire, you shoved the unfair contract onto him. If this is not contempt, what else would be?”

“If this is not contempt,” Lloyd mulled, “ Maybe I should call it a threat, just like the thing you all did to us the last time.”

Lloyd’s gaze quickly traveled to the viscount, who flinched. A sneer appeared on Lloyd’s face.

“I’m holding the viscount in contempt? I had no idea. I was just doing the exact thing you people did to our baron the last time. Are we not allowed to act this way?”

“What are you saying…”

“You used the river, the biggest lifeline and most important source of water to my fiefdom, to threaten the baron in this same manner. You demanded that he give you half of the Maritz Wetland. That was the deal, you said.”

Sir Curno didn’t say anything.

“You know, I was impressed. I thought, wow, that’s how you strike a deal! That’s the way to succeed in life! Right, this is the generous and

heartwarming trade you should make with your neighbors! That's what I learned."

"So I am doing exactly the same thing."

"Why? Am I not allowed to?" Lloyd tilted his head sideways.

Sir Curno, who was dumbstruck, gritted his teeth.

How can he respond back so quickly…?

Sir Curno found himself without an answer. Of course, he knew very well that what the viscount did to the barony was an obvious act of blackmail. It was truly over the line.

The viscount is my lord, the person to whom I swore my allegiance for life. So I don't make moral judgments and consider if his actions are right. I simply act as a trustworthy sword and protect him!

It was the same right now. Lloyd Frontera was threatening his viscount, forcing him to enter a deal that was disadvantageous on their part. It didn't matter in the slightest that he had blackmailed the barony. The only justice for Sir Curno lay in the viscount's power and fortune.

So I must stop him. I must ensure that the lord does not enter this wrongful contract.

Sir Curno had heard the entire conversation just outside the reception room. He had heard the tricks Lloyd pulled to mock the viscount, the way he pushed forward the wrongful contract in the end, and how viciously high the water bill was. He had heard and understood everything that was said. He became keenly aware of one thing: *I must block the contract come hell or high water.* That contract was a sharp and massive straw the Frontera barony was sticking into the viscounty to slurp all its resources. Once it got stuck, it would be impossible to remove. Thus, the viscounty would economically be shackled to the barony well in the future. A large portion of the profit the viscounty earned from the Laconata fabric would be continuously taken away.

Moreover, that's not the end of it.

The viscounty would be incapable of producing the Laconata fabric without the water provided by the barony's water supply system. That meant even if the barony unilaterally raised the water bill in the future, the viscount wouldn't be left with any other choice but to agree. The Laconata cloth would be held hostage. Realizing the viscount was on the brink of signing the papers, Sir Curno, driven by urgency, forcefully pushed the door open to make his entrance into the room. He could get reprimanded by the lord later or receive harsher punishments for his interference. However, he had to stop the signing, even if it required him to behave impudently. It was this eagerness that put him into deep thought at the moment.

I can never win against him in an argument.

Sir Curno was not an eloquent speaker who was good at arguing. He was a man of action. However, he wanted to win this dispute. He wanted to use every means possible to drive Lloyd Frontera away. Thinking that it was the only way to serve the lord, Sir Curno sought ways to fight Lloyd.

And just then, an idea popped into his head.

I'm going with the method that suits me best.

He was a fighter. A fighter used swords, not words. That was an unchanging truth even at this very moment.

"Lloyd Frontera."

Sir Curno lifted his head and glared at the young master.

"I, Lugno Curno, the son of Vargo Curno, formally request a duel with Lloyd Frontera, the successor to the Frontera family."

He spoke with confidence. The room instantly became hushed. The viscount was struggling to figure out a way to stop his knight. Javier was watching the scene beside Lloyd, and Lloyd was standing opposite Sir Curno. They all clamped their mouths shut. The viscount looked terrified,

Javier looked intrigued, and Lloyd furrowed his one eyebrow. Everyone stared at Sir Curno.

It worked.

Sir Curno smiled faintly. The request for a duel. This was the most powerful move he could make at the moment. It was also the most surefire plan.

Of course. That prick is a noble, after all.

Sir Curno was confident that Lloyd would not be able to turn it down. One of the greatest shame for a nobleman was avoiding a duel. Saying no was the same as announcing to the world that he was an unworthy coward. Sir Curno thought that Lloyd would be the same.

He'll have his pride as a noble, so he's going to accept it. He has no choice. Plus, I heard that he had already won against Sir Neumann before in a duel.

Just then, Sir Curno remembered the rumor. At first, he was shocked to hear it.

Though he wasn't as good as me, Sir Neumann wasn't an easy opponent. This brat had to have gotten confident after winning against him. There's no chance that he will reject a request for a duel.

No, even if he was not confident, he would say yes nonetheless. Instead, he would send that youthful silver-haired knight to fight for him. Sir Curno expected that to happen. Thus. he planned on his next move. He would demand that vicious bastard nullify the contract if he won.

So take my request for the duel now...

"Hm. No thanks."

Lloyd's casual response rang aloud, tapping Sir Curno's eardrums. Dumbfounded, Sir Curno blankly let out a noise.``Huh?"

"Didn't you hear me? I said no," repeated Lloyd.

“What...”

Sir Curno’s eyes enlarged. Lloyd looked at the knight with a sneer on his face. “Let me ask you one thing. Why should I take up your request for a duel?”

“Well, of course...”

“Because that’s the way to protect a noble’s honor? Are you a fool?”

Sir Curno didn’t answer.

“Why would I duel you right now?”

“But if you don’t accept it, you are...”

“An unworthy coward? Well, fine. I’ll be an unworthy coward then,” said Lloyd with nonchalance.

“What?”

“Didn’t you hear me? I said I would be an unworthy coward.”

“Goodness, you scare me. What’s wrong with this neighborhood? I try to strike a mutually constructive deal, and a knight barges into the room and challenges me to a sword fight?”

“Hey! Lloyd Frontera!”

“Eh? Why?”

“Accept my request for a duel!” bawled Sir Curno.

“I said no!” said Lloyd defiantly.

“But!”

“But what?”

Sir Curno couldn’t come up with anything to say.

“Is that how much you want to fight with me?” demanded Lloyd.

“Why are you acting so clingy? Do you have anxiety issues?”

“That’s because...”

“Stop being so dependent on others, okay? Buddha said it, too. Be your own lamp, seek no other refuge but yourself. So, mind your own business.”

“Never did I hear...”

“Just listen, man. This is the reason why you study when you are young. Haven’t you ever heard that the knowledge you acquire from books in your teenage years lasts a lifetime?”

“I knew the only thing you’d be good at is wielding some swords and nothing else. Tsk.”

“Wait, I...”

“So will you piss off now? I don’t think you’re understanding the current situation, so let me just spell it out. Your lord and I are having an important business meeting, and look how you put him in a difficult place. How so? It’s because if your lord doesn’t seal the deal now, he has to shut down his beloved Laconata dye workshop forever.”

“So, do know that your master will be more miserable the more you act like this. I don’t know if you know, but Bobby McFerrin once told us to not worry, to be happy. Know what that means?”

“I don’t know...”

“It means concerns about your money will make you unhappy,” interrupted Lloyd again.

“I’m telling you, the more you act like this, the unhappier your lord will become. Do you still not get what’s going on?”

Sir Curno was at an absolute loss of words. Lloyd's sneer deepened. Once he had Sir Curno under control, he turned to the viscount. Cocking his head to the side, Lloyd asked, "Tell me you didn't feel a slight ray of hope or anything like that in what your knight just did."

"If you expected me to take the offer for the duel, then I am telling you to throw that thought away. It's better for your mental health to let go of useless hope as soon as possible. So, let's get back to business, shall we?"

Lloyd sat down and held out his hand. Lloyd tapped the contract paper on the table with his index finger. The place he had tapped was the last signature block. That was where the viscount stopped because of Sir Curno's interference.

"Now, please sign it."

As though he was a war victor forcing the losing country to sign a treaty, Lloyd patronizingly spoke with a smile on his face. The viscount, looking sour, grabbed his pen. His pen trembled as it moved toward the signature block. Perhaps, that was the reason why Sir Curno, who was treated like he wasn't there, made up his mind to cross the line and take drastic action to prevent his lord from signing the contract.

How dare you! Anyone who holds my lord in contempt will never be left alone. Even if it means my knightley status is stripped off!

He clenched his teeth and glared at Lloyd, the foolish young master from the neighboring fiefdom, the man who sat with his back exposed as he forced a wrongful contract to the lord.

Now is the time!

Sir Curno was sure Lloyd would be caught off-guard. Sir Curno's eyes flashed with ferocious animosity. His right hand moved and clutched the hilt of his long sword tucked into his waist. He then subtly lowered his body, shifting the center of his weight to the ground.

At the same time, he twisted his waist. All of the muscles on his upper body, abs, chest, shoulders, and arms, jerked to the right. A large sword was drawn out from its sheath on his left waist. He didn't merely use his arm strength to pull the sword out, the sword was pulled by planting his muscular upper and lower torso against the ground. He demonstrated as much speed as he did strength.

The sword was stretched out the moment it drew from its sheath. The blade glinted sharply against the light, making a beeline toward Lloyd's back.

Deep, but not enough to kill him! I shall slay just right!

He wanted to injure him just enough to keep him unconscious for days or keep him bedridden for months. He would shed blood to buy some time in order to stop the contract from being signed. Guided by such determination, Sir Curno's sword violently swooshed against the air. However, just before it slayed Lloyd in the back, his blade was slashed in half.

Sir Curno snapped open his eyes. It happened in a matter of seconds, so he didn't have any time to respond. Before he knew it, a sword blade flashed beside him. It slashed through his own sword in one stroke. The sliced blade twisted and flew in the air, brushing against his cheek before it plunged into the wall behind him. At the same time, Sir Curno heard someone put their sword down along with an icy warning.

"Next time, it will be your neck."

Javier confidently put his sword back as if he did nothing. Though hazy, it just dawned on Sir Curno what just happened. His snapped sword, the wound on his cheek, and the sword shard stuck to the wall were all caused by Javier. Terror instinctively swept over his whole being, and just like that, Sir Curno wet his pants.

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Chapter 60: The Devil’s Contract (5)

The viscount finished signing the contract. It was done in a snap, his pen marking the paper without a second of hesitation. This was understandable coming from the viscount, after all, the last of his hopes were crushed into nothing.

“Sir Curno, was it? I could tell from the moment the knight came in and threw a fit that the viscount was waiting to see how the situation panned out. He was just too transparent.”

Lloyd spoke as he sat on the back of the saddle. They were on their way to the barony.

Javier, who was in the front, nodded. “I thought the same as well.”

It really was the case. Sure, there was no way of stopping Sir Curno from throwing himself into the reception room. What happened after could have been handled by the viscount. He could have yelled or lashed out at the knight to keep a tight rein on him, but instead, he did nothing.

“He was betting on the senior knight to turn the tables. It was his last hope, and you struck it down,” said Lloyd.

“As expected, I was right.”

“Yeah, so how do you feel about getting a new title?”

“What do you mean by a new title?”

“Urinator Creator.”

“It’s true, isn’t it? You wielded your sword and sliced Sir Curno’s sword in half. That made the knight weep in panic and wet his pants. Right?”

“Anyway,” continued Lloyd, “that shameful event is going to keep Sir Curno humble. He won’t be able to stand up straight for a while. Surely,

it’ll keep him tossing and turning in bed all night. If I were him, I’d pack my bags and move to another fiefdom tonight. No, I think I’d cross over to another continent where no one knows me. Anyway, good job. You were awesome.”

“I simply stopped a coward from striking someone from behind, that’s all.”

“Exactly! You are the Urinator Creator.”

Javier didn’t say anything again.

“Why? Do you not like it?”

“I do not think that deserves an answer.”

“Can I assume that you like the nickname then, huh?”

“Never. I do not like it.”

Javier clutched and gave an unnecessarily hard pull at the horse's reins. Lloyd smiled mischievously.

“Anyway, rumors of your swordsmanship will spread to all corners of the world.”

It was true. Javier had cut Sir Curno’s sword in half. Slicing through a sword in one stroke was definitely not an easy feat. Heck, it was hard to do even if one struck against a flat surface. Sir Curno was the senior knight of the viscounty. The man had a reputation for possessing decent sword skills.

“Rumors say that Sir Curno is bordering on being a mid-level sword expert. What do you think? How did it feel to clash swords with him?” asked Lloyd.

“He was better than what the rumors said. I felt that the man’s skills were clearly beyond a mid-level sword expert. That’s for sure.”

“And yet, you sliced through his sword in one stroke.”

“Is that so?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, thanks to that, the rumor will spread not only to the viscounty but to nearby provinces.”

“What kind of rumor do you think it will be?”

“Perhaps,” said Lloyd, “it will be something to the effect of Javier Asrahan, the youngest knight of the Frontera barony in the corner of the eastern region, defeated a mid-level sword expert of a neighboring fiefdom.”

“Then I will receive the qualifier that I am a high-level sword expert,” said Javier.

“I would assume so.”

That probably would happen. It was only possible to slice through an opponent’s sword when you were one level higher. As such, from now on, the Frontera barony would be known for having a high-level sword expert as a knight.

“It will come with both the good and bad,” announced Lloyd.

“The good and bad?”

“First, it will reduce the number of people who look down on our fiefdom. We now have a fatal and destructive weapon.”

“Then, what is bad?” asked Javier.

“You.”

“Excuse me...?” Javier glanced slightly behind.

“A lot of people will want you from now on.”

“Want me? Who in the world does?”

“Who else? The countless lords, great merchants, and such nearby our fiefdom.”

“Do you mean that they will try to hire me?”

“Of course,” Lloyd said as he nodded before continuing.

“Think about it. You are a high-level sword expert. And what’s more, you’re a young twenty-year-old who's still wet behind the ears. If you were a powerful lord or great merchant, what do you think you would do after hearing the news?”

“I would want him to be my right-hand man...”

“Right?”

“Yes.”

“Yeah, so they’ll try to make you their aide and pour money into your training. Why? It’s because you are only twenty. After just ten years of diligently investing in you, they could obtain a sword master who’s only about thirty years old.”

A thirty-year-old sword master. That would be groundbreaking news. Especially when all the existing sword masters were over forty years old.

It’d be like having twenty-year-old Guan Yu, Zhao Yun, Michael Jordan, or Messi around me.

If anybody succeeded in bringing Javier to their side, he would easily be able to serve for at least two generations. There was no possibility for the other lords, influential merchants, and perhaps even for the king to leave this man of talent alone.

“We might go through some rough times,” said Lloyd.

He looked at Javier in the front. He could only see the back of the knight, so he could not read his expression. However, Lloyd could feel what expression Javier was making.

“I see, rough times. It does not matter. I do not have any intention to serve any other lord.”

Of course, Javier has always been this kind of man.

His character was the same in the original novel, *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* He wasn’t swayed by people around him. That was true even when the Frontera barony was falling apart in the novel. He could have left the dying fiefdom if he wanted to at any time and gone to serve a more powerful and promising lord and live a comfortable life.

However, Javier didn’t do that. Even when the baron died, no, even after his death, Javier remained loyal. He didn’t serve another lord until the very end, even after he became a sword master. Powerful princes, kings, and emperors stuck out their hands to work with him, but he declined all of them. Instead, he savagely said that the only lord he would serve in his lifetime was Baron Frontera.

Anyway, this guy is just something.

It wasn’t easy living like him. No, it was realistically impossible. However, that impossibility was possible for Javier, who stubbornly stuck to this principle his whole life.

I won’t have to worry about him running off to other masters.

However, the competition for Javier would still exist. So it was imperative for Lloyd to make sure that the barony would not be affected by it. Lloyd was mentally planning for the future when he suddenly let out a chuckle. He chuckled because he remembered another knight who stayed loyal to Baron Frontera in the novel.

“Oh, by the way, did Sir Bayern say anything to you?” asked Lloyd,

“I do not know what you mean.”

“Of course you do. I’m talking about the mana blast you’ve been using during every construction.”

“Oh.” Javier nodded, finally understanding what Lloyd meant.

“Yes, Sir Bayern did say something to me after he saw me use the mana blast.”

“What did he say?” asked Lloyd.

“That it was excellent.”

“That’s it?”

“Yes.”

“He didn’t react by saying something like he wants to learn the skill himself or wants to check your sword fighting level?”

“Oh, he did say once that he was envious of me,” Javier replied.

“That was all.”

“Sounds like Bayern all right.”

It was just like the novel. Lloyd recalled what had been said a few times in the novel about Sir Bayern.

The novel says that he’s mediocre in terms of talent, but he’s steadfast, fair, and unselfish.

Just as the novel had described, it appeared that the knight didn’t feel much envy when Javier got stronger and better. No, it appeared more like he welcomed it.

He must be thinking that it is better for the fiefdom now that Javier is getting stronger.

The man prioritized the development and betterment of the fiefdom over his competitive spirit. Lloyd told himself that he made the right choice to entrust him with the task of managing the civil engineering group. At the

same time, Lloyd thought that it was about time that he helped Sir Bayern get stronger.

“By the way,” said Javier.

“Hmm?”

“Why did you do that a while ago?”

Javier’s sharp question pierced into Lloyd’s trance, instantly shattering it. Lloyd tilted his head.

“A while ago? What do you mean?”

“I am referring to the request for a duel by Sir Curno.”

There was an edge in Javier’s voice. It was as if he was pointing out a mistake.

“It was quite rash of you.”

“Wait, because I said no to the duel?” said Lloyd.

“Instead of flatly saying no, it is my opinion that you should have given him a clear reason behind your rejection.”

Javier went on.

“You will only become the center of gossip if you reject a duel without any evident reason. Of course, Master Lloyd, I know that you are not the type of person who cares about that. But you are not an ordinary individual. You are clearly a member of the Frontera family, therefore…”

“My perfunctory and flat rejection of the duel will only affect the reputation of the fiefdom and the barony. That’s what you want to say, right?” Lloyd said, finishing Javier’s sentence.

“Yes...” Javier nodded in front of Lloyd. He then added, “If it was Master Julian, he would have dealt with the matter more sophisticatedly.”

“Julian?”

“Yes.”

“Tsk, why do you have to bring him up?”

Lloyd couldn’t help but chuckle. That was because he suddenly recalled another character in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Julian, Lloyd’s younger brother was five years younger than Lloyd and the second son of the baron. Unlike the drunkard Lloyd, Julian was hard-working and kind. He seemed to only take after the good traits of the baron and baroness.

That’s why the baron has high expectations for him, and he’s now studying abroad in one of the academies in the capital.

In the novel, he met a tragic end. He was kicked out of the academy because he couldn’t pay the tuition. Later that same night, he bumped into a burglar in the back alley, much of his bad luck. Julian refused the burglar’s demand to hand over an old pendant from his mother, the baroness. In the process of protecting the jewel, the boy was stabbed. In the dark, solitary alleyway with no one passing by, he pitifully passed away. That was the fate of Julian Frontera in the novel.

But of course, it will be a bit different now.

Since the barony didn’t go under, Julian wouldn’t be kicked out of the academy. He wouldn’t be roaming around the backstreet like in the novel and bumping into a burglar. While such thoughts kept Lloyd in a state of trance, Javier continued his nagging by throwing truth bombs on him.

“...fore, you should be a little more mature like your younger brother, Julian Frontera. Your behaviors and actions have bigger consequences than you think. You need to have a sense of responsibility for how the reputation and honor of the Frontera family depend on your actions.”

“Oh, sure,” Lloyd agreed.

“Of course, I cannot deny that you have achieved a great accomplishment this time. It is deserving of praise, surely. It is exactly for that very reason that I dare think your more noble-like behavior would be icing on the cake.”

“So, are you saying that I should act more honorably the next time I reject a duel request?”

“Yes,” said Javier.

“Instead of provoking the other party like a maverick and leaving my back unprotected?”

“Yes.”

“But Javier, I have you.”

“Excuse me...?”

One seemingly casual remark caused Javier to flinch as he heard it. Lloyd tittered.

“You were beside me. I trusted that you would have my back no matter what situation I found myself in. After all, you are just that much capable and reliable.”

For some reason, Javier didn’t respond. Lloyd cocked his head. “Hmm. No reaction, eh? Didn’t my words give you the chills?”

Silence.

“Hey?”

Silence again.

“Did you pass out?”

“I didn’t pass out. But-”

“But?”

“I barely held myself from throwing up.”

“Wow. You almost threw up?”

“Yes.”

“Was my sincerity that awful?”

“Yes.”

Javier’s head nodded up and down as if that was obviously the case.

Just then, however, a completely contradictory message popped in front of Loyd’s eyes.

[Javier Asrahan is moved by your sincere words.]

[The uncomfortable doubts Javier Asrahan has been harboring toward you are disappearing.]

[Your countless kind and considerate gestures are finally being interpreted by Javier Asrahan as they are without any misunderstanding.]

The cascading message appeared, using the back of Javier’s silver hair as the background.

Lloyd widened his eyes as he looked at it.

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by fourteen points.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: plus five]

[You have earned 252 RP by greatly improving relationships with the main character.]

[Current RP: 1607]

[The intimacy level with Javier Asrahan has increased two levels from <Awkward> and <Everyday Strangers> to <Average Regard>.]

[You have earned fifty RP as a bonus for the two-level increase in intimacy.]

[Current RP: 1657]

Lloyd earned more than 300 RP in an instant.

This is almost like when I achieved a great social achievement.

The pack included a total of eighteen RP. Lloyd heartily stared at the back of Javier's head as if he were looking at a bar of gold. If he could, he wanted to stroke Javier's chestnut-like head.

At the same time, Lloyd realized one thing.

There was a reason why my likeability with this one increased only menially.

Honestly, Lloyd had done a lot for Javier up to this point. He had cured his malignant insomnia for him, helped complete the Asrahan Core Technique when Javier was stuck and risked his life and piggybacked Javier out of the ant cave. Not only that, he had taught Javier the mana blast, which was an advanced skill for the Asrahan Core Technique. There were more than a few things that Javier should be grateful for. As such, it wouldn't have been strange if his likeability soared through the sky.

But it was different in reality.

His likeability barely increased with this man for some strange reason. Whenever he saw an increase, the change was as small and minute as an ant's eye booger. At first, Lloyd was confused, but eventually, he accepted it.

I'd thought that it was because of his uniquely cynical attitude.

But looking back, that wasn't the case.

It was because he didn't trust me and doubted my sincerity.

Javier had literally built a wall around his heart. That was why Javier took all his kind gestures with a grain of salt.

You petty brat!

That was one thought he had. However, on the flip side, Lloyd somewhat understood when he put himself in Javier's shoes.

He was saved and then raised by the baron as a child. H*e's seen all of Lloyd's foolishness throughout the entire time.*

From kindergarten to when he came of age. Javier grew up to witness and watch all sorts of nasty things Lloyd did for many, many years. As such, Javier must have decided that Lloyd's vile and horrid behavior was almost like an ancient tradition that couldn't be discarded. A few months of acting like a changed man wasn't enough to make Javier come around.

Javier isn't a softie who opens his heart to others that easily.

It was Javier's personality. He was inherently a careful person, careful of getting attached to others. He showed his true sincerity when he opened up, but that didn't happen easily. His heart had finally started opening, though it was just by a few millimeters. Lloyd grinned at the back of Javier's head.

"Hey," Lloyd called.

"Yes."

"Did you hate me that much?"

"May I be frank?"

"Yeah," permitted Lloyd.

"I hate you even now."

"Wow."

“Do you remember the first time I grabbed a wooden sword when I was six?” asked Javier.

“No, not at all.”

“Master Lloyd, you broke the first ever wooden sword the lord had bestowed on me right in front of my eyes.”

“Woah...” gasped Lloyd.

“Actually, I have not thrown away the broken wooden sword.”

“Did you keep it in your room?”

“Yes.”

“Why?” asked Lloyd.

“As a way to never forget your gratitude toward the baron or something?”

“No, I keep it to not forget what you have done.”

“Ack...”

Hah, Lloyd Frontera. Seriously, how much of a piece of trash were you.…

Lloyd became speechless. Now, he understood the reason behind Javier’s grouchy attitude all this time. Javier continued to speak.

“So I still horribly despise you even now. I ask you, please try your best not to act as if we are friends.”

“Ah, is that so?”

“Yes.”

[Javier Asrahan is throwing a tantrum.]

[Javier Asrahan is letting go of the deep-seated resentment in his heart.]

[Javier Asrahan, unlike his seemingly cynical attitude, feels slightly favorable towards you for listening to his words.]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by one point.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: plus six]

[You have earned 18 RP by slightly improving your relationship with the main character.]

[Current RP: 1675]

This lying bastard…

A bitter smile escaped from Lloyd. After that, Javier's nagging and grouchy mumbling continued. The complaints didn't sound cold in Lloyd's ears anymore. It was grouchy but not cold. Lloyd happily accepted his tantrum. The two of them were on a galloping horse, so they couldn't read each other's expressions.

However, they were wearing a similar smile. The sun had already set by the time they arrived safely at the barony. When they arrived, they found the fiefdom holding a modest festival to celebrate the completion of the water supply system. Aside from that, fresh and welcoming news awaited Lloyd.

"Right on time. Did your meeting with the viscount go smoothly?" asked the baron.

"Yes."

The baron walked up and welcomed Lloyd first.

"Good job. You did very well."

"Thank you," replied Lloyd.

"All right, tell me about it a little later since everything went well. For now, I want you to take a look at this."

The baron then pulled something out of his pocket. It was a message written on a rolled piece of parchment paper.

“It came in this afternoon. Do you remember what you asked of me the last time?” asked the baron.

“What I asked of you?”

“Yes.”

“Oh, do you mean my request for you to look into potential buyers for the treasures I obtained from the orc tribe?”

“That is right. An answer came earlier this afternoon.”

The baron flashed a big smile.

“Count Cremo in Cremo, the city of commerce, expressed his willingness to purchase all of the treasures at once, and he sent you a message asking you to bring them there.”

The baron opened the letter with a smile. Lloyd smiled the same when he read it. At last, Lloyd had the chance to sell all the treasure sitting in the storage.

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Chapter 61: Erecting the Statue (1)

Cremo, the city of commerce, was the central city of Cremona, the eastern province of the kingdom. It went without saying that Count Cremo was the great lord of the province. In other words, he was the senior boss of Baron Frontera.

To compare it with South Korea, the guy is, hmm... a governor?

He wielded the greatest influence in the province. The count's power could even be seen far into the kingdom. Thus, Lloyd cocked his head in curiosity.

"Hmm... The count will really be purchasing the treasures?"

"I was told he is. Why else would he send this letter?" the baron replied.

"But why?"

"What do you mean?"

"Those treasures don't actually hold much value because the orcs treated them as fitness tools and horribly wore them down. They are chipped and cracked in several places."

It was true. Regardless of how precious a treasure was, it needed proper maintenance.

The prolonged years of using them as fitness tools ran them down pretty bad. At first glance, they did look valuable. If they were wiped well, they even became nice and glossy. However, it was a slightly different story upon a closer look. There were dents and chips here and there. There were quite a lot of them, actually.

"So," explained Lloyd, "I actually thought our customer would be one of the provincial nobles who wish to purchase treasures at a low price and boast around or the merchants who benefit by acting a middleman to such customers."

That was what Lloyd had in mind. After all, these were used treasures. That was why Lloyd was confused all the more.

A count with his status wouldn’t need to buy these used-up treasures.

Certainly, if he desired, he had the means to splurge his money away on new and shiny treasures. He could even call for a jewel master to personally make them. Instead of doing that, he was trying to purchase these used treasures. Something certainly didn’t add up. It was like if a CEO of a multinational company purchased a used car because he wanted a luxury vehicle, or a rich lady going through thrift shops to get her hands on designer bags.

“Is the count planning on using them for another purpose?”

Lloyd asked. The baron shrugged.

“I do not know. But...”

The baron stroked his chin as he frowned.

“According to rumors, the count has recently been planning to build a huge statue in Cremo city.”

“A statue?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“I am not sure about that. This is my presumption, but it looks like he plans to decorate the statue by detaching the gems he buys from us.”

“Oh, that makes sense.”

Lloyd nodded his head at last. Small jewels would be used to decorate parts of the huge statue. Lloyd could understand the count after hearing that explanation.

It’ll certainly save him some money if he detaches the gems from the secondhand treasures and reuses them. After all, statues are meant to be enjoyed from afar, so even the lightly-scratched jewels won’t be much of an issue.

Lloyd recalled the chandelier among the treasures stored in the storage. It must have once been used to lighten the hall of a noble estate. However, when it came into the hands of the orcs, it turned into a giant hula hoop. Thankfully, the gems densely studded around the chandelier were mostly in one piece save for some. The count would be able to take quite a large number of gems from it.

What a frugal count he is.

No matter, Lloyd was happy that he secured a buyer. The news was even more welcomed since he could sell all the treasures to one buyer. Lloyd was greeted with good news upon arrival. To give what he owed, Lloyd shared his own good news with the baron.

“Then, is it my turn now?”

“Is it about your visit to the viscounty?” asked the baron.

“Yes, I’m referring to the water bill I told you about this morning.”

“How did Viscount Lacona react?”

“Whew, you should have seen it yourself.”

Lloyd began to chat, walking through what happened in the reception room with the viscount. Lloyd shared in detail how pitiful the viscount made himself look. As the baron listened to the story, the corners of his lips curled upward in overwhelming happiness. His expression looked like someone who finally cured their century-long indigestion. His cheekbones rose, reaching to the sky. Honestly, his reaction was understandable.

It must have been terribly humiliating when the viscount sent Sir Curno to threaten him.

The threat had pushed him into a corner. That day, the baron was mortified not by the viscount himself but by a menial knight sent by the viscount. There couldn’t be anything more humiliating than that.

But right now...He was listening to the story of how the viscount, the very enemy that shamed him, signed the contract in tears. As if that wasn’t enough, Sir Curno wet his pants. These events would become a painful memory for his tormentors who’d humiliated him. How could he not be elated when he heard the story?

I’m sure the words flow into his ear canals like honey.

Lloyd became happy at the sight of the joyful baron and the sight of his people enjoying the town festival comforted his heart as well.

That’s why I must pay off the debt fast.

Lloyd recalled the first day he came to this place. It was a ruckus as his manor was on the verge of being foreclosed. Ever since then, he had worked very hard.

I’m almost there. Just a bit more.

Little by little, he started to believe that he could pay off the debt. Just like his rising hopes, the night of the small festival deepened.

* * *

The following morning, Lloyd began to get busy. Time wasn’t on his side. That was the truth he always held tight in the corner of his heart. It was no different today even though he had fallen asleep once the sun started rising.

I’ve got mountains of work to do! All right! Let’s go!

Rising from bed early and getting ready for the day was a habit Loyd had cultivated since he was in Korea. He always woke up at the same hour. When it became bright outside, his eyes opened, and he woke Javier up. He started preparing for his trip to Cremo, the city of commerce.

“I fear it will cause trouble if I have too many people with me. Please keep the size of security to a minimum,” said Lloyd.

“Are you certain that it will be fine? If you consider your safety...”

“It is all right,” said Lloyd.

“I have Sir Asrahan with me.”

“Hmm. You are right, yet...”

Lloyd planned on personally going to Cremo City himself. Knowing that, the baron had put together a delegation of one hundred members. Lloyd was obviously shocked.

“The more mouths we have, the more supplies we will need. Besides, the civil engineers need to stay here and keep constructing the heated flooring system.”

It was true. The amount of food and other cargo they needed would increase when there were too many mouths to feed. Their pace would decrease in proportion to the increase in items they had to carry. Moreover, winter was drawing near.

“The contract I signed in the spring specifies that the ondol construction will be finished before winter arrives. We should have finished up the entire construction by now, but we didn’t,” explained Lloyd.

It was because of the construction of the water supply system. The unplanned project required the mobilization of workers on the ondol construction, putting it to a halt.

“So I will bring the bare minimum number of civil engineers with me. I must finish the ondol construction before winter arrives, even if it means I have to put everyone on the project.”

“Then, how many do you plan to take with you?”

“I believe about twenty people would be enough to guard and load the treasures on the carriage”

“Are you sure that’s sufficient?” asked the baron again.

“Yes.”

As per Lloyd’s adamant will, twenty civil engineers, Javier, and Lloyd were the ones chosen to travel to the city of commerce. However, the final decision on the delegation size didn’t mean that Lloyd would set off for the journey right away. There was a task they needed to do before departing. It was constructing the pipes for the water supply system for the dye workshop in the viscounty.

Regardless of anything, I did sign the contract with him.

Lloyd needed to hurry and install it. That way, he would be able to get the large water bill as quickly as possible.

“All right, do not rush yourselves. Take it one step at a time. What’s the number one priority in construction sites?” asked Lloyd.

“Safety!”

“Good. You’ve done this an awful amount of times on the mountain, yes?”

“Yes, Young Master!”

“Then let’s get right to it!”

“Woah!!!”

Lloyd mobilized a portion of the civil engineering group from the purification plant of the fiefdom to the dye workshop of the viscounty. They repeated the job they had done over and over again in the mountain range. Ppodong dug the designated route and the soldiers smoothened it. They inserted, connected, and buried giant bamboo pipes. Everything took place in one unified flow.

The work was so smooth because I had everything planned out beforehand.

From the survey to design, Lloyd had finished everything before visiting the viscount and getting the contract signed.

The same went for the giant bamboo. He had already acquired the extra bamboo stalks in advance when he constructed the facility for his fiefdom in the mountain. Lloyd had already pruned them up and added stiffeners around altogether. In other words, everything was set.

Thus, all they needed was for Ppodong to dig the ground at the site and the soldiers to smoothen it up. The pipes could be installed right away.

Working my ass off back in the mountain felt like grilling for a barbecue, but this job feels like I'm tossing some frozen meals into the microwave.

It was very convenient and quick. Within fifteen days, Lloyd was able to construct almost all of the pipes. There was a difference in elevation between the Frontera fiefdom and the viscounty, which Lloyd adequately overcame with the eastern mountain range. Thanks to that, the average elevation of the overall pipes was approximately 0.7 percent.

This is good enough.

On the last day, when the pipes were connected, the viscounty's dye workshop finally saw the provision of the first water supply system. The water wasn't limewater anymore. It was the water that directly flowed from Lake Kapua. That eventually revived the viscounty's specialty product, the Laconata.

Its former color and gloss returned. Viscount Lacona was obviously overwhelmed at the sight.

"Finally. Finally..."

He gasped out between his sobs.

"How do you like it? Don't you think you made the right decision to install the water supply system?"

“Truly, yes. It is beyond me why I hesitated to sign the contract for this...”

“Well, of course. It was because of the water bill.”

“Please make sure that you do not get behind on your water bill from the first month.”

“Understood,” said Viscount Lacona.

The viscount had been overwhelmed with emotion and hugging the recovered Laconata cloth. But the word ‘water bill’ instantly dampened his spirit, and his face turned gray and sullen. Lloyd’s lips curved into a villainous smile.

Oh, pushovers like him are always welcome.

Not a single cell in him felt sorry or pity towards the viscount. The crisis was turned into an opportunity. It was the viscount himself who first put Lloyd in crisis. By overcoming it, he used the water bill as a straw to suck the viscount’s wallet dry. It was a titanium straw that no one would dare think of even touching for at least a couple of decades. Those weren’t the only things he earned.

The moment Lloyd turned around, abandoning the sullen viscount, a clear alarm rang with several messages sliding down in front of his eyes.

[You have succeeded in establishing a water supply system.]

[This marks a significant milestone in the history of the Lorasia continent.]

[The water supply system and its usage will be recorded for many years as one of the leading examples of civil construction in the kingdom and continent.]

[Your name will be recorded in the history of construction for the kingdom and continent.]

[For your first-ever continental achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have earned 600 RP.]

[Current RP: 2275]

Lloyd stopped moving, but the messages kept appearing.

[The rumors about your great achievement will spread to nearby regions.]

[In particular, the bureaucrats and civil engineers of the kingdom will be deeply interested in the engineering and social value of the water supply system.]

[You have started to become famous as a developer.]

[Those who come across the rumors about you will show greater trust toward your construction plans than before.]

My reward for introducing the water supply system, huh.

Lloyd grasped the meaning of the messages as he slowly read them.

I was wondering why I didn't get any rewards after I built the water supply system for my fiefdom.

That was something Lloyd was actually curious about.

But when he saw the messages popping in front of him, he was able to guess the reason.

This time, it wasn't just about installing the water supply system. I had to meet the condition of properly using the built structure.

He couldn't just lay down the water supply system. The condition for the accomplishment was to actually provide water using the installed facility and ultimately introduce a system that would be 'used' to collect water bills.

Good. Excellent.

The reward messages beautifully adorned the front of his eyes. Lloyd smiled in contentment as he looked at them.

I'm overflowing with RP.

This was the largest amount of RP he had ever received at once so far. But there was more.

Authority and credence as a developer is a huge reward. Though it wasn't expressed in numbers, I'm sure it's the largest reward I received.

Lloyd wanted to continue getting big construction projects down the road. That was how he would be able to make a lot of money and pay the debt of the baron. Just now, in the process of doing so, he had gained authority and credence as a developer. As such, it would be easier from now on to win over clients for construction projects.

This reward will help me throughout the future.

He liked it very much. Behind it, there were smaller rewards that followed. He earned five points of likeability from both the baron and baroness. Two points from Sir Bayern, who oversaw the construction. Four points from all the residents in his fiefdom. Thanks to that, he garnered over 126 RP, and people started to have fonder feelings toward Lloyd.

"Travel safely," the baron said.

It was the day after the water supply system was connected to the viscounty. Lloyd departed to Cremo, the city of commerce. The baron couple escorted Lloyd on his way. The baron showered Lloyd with endless words of concern.

"Be careful all the time, and do not act rash wherever you are. Do you understand?"

"I'll make sure to remember your words."

"And if something happens, make sure you hide behind Sir Asrahan."

“Yes, I promise that I will do that.”

“If you are in danger, make sure you run away before anything else.”

“Then, what about the soldiers?”

“Uhm, then run away with them together.”

The baroness was no better than her husband when it came to showering Lloyd with endless concerns.

“If things get hard, come back anytime. Promise me that you will never go on a strange, dark road or anywhere dangerous like that.”

“Yes, yes. I promise I won’t.”

“Make sure you do not skip meals.”

“Yes, I will eat on time,” said Lloyd again.

“And keep your blanket on when you sleep. Do not kick it away.”

“Mhm, yes.”

“And take this,” said the baroness.

“What is this?”

“It’s a talisman.”

“This cutesy pink doll is a talisman...?”

The baroness held out the talisman, and Lloyd slightly frowned when he took it. It was a teddy bear, too cute and chubby to call a talisman. Not only that, the color was pink, the pastel shade that teenage girls loved. However, the look on the baroness's face was serious as she handed it over to Lloyd.

“Do not doubt its power. You should watch your words, Lloyd.”

“Uhm, but...”

“Your mother spent all night making that.”

“Oh...”

“Come on. Take it instead of just standing there.”

“But what power does it have, really?”

“I heard that it keeps away nightmares if you sleep with it every day.”

“Woah.”

“You see, sleep is necessary for a good life and luck naturally follows behind it. So I want you to tightly hug this at night while you are away. Okay?”

This was the baroness’s way of showing concern for him. He couldn’t bear to reject her efforts. At that moment, Lloyd was suddenly hit with thoughts about his mother back in Korea.

I guess all mothers are the same.

Even when things seemed unnecessary and at times pestering and embarrassing, they never stopped embracing and taking care of you. Why he thought he didn’t need any of it at the time was beyond him. He didn’t know why he thought they were a cumbersome existence. Lloyd regretted it as he looked back.

I should have accepted her when she reached out. I should have thanked her more.

Lloyd regretted that he didn’t do so in the past. So, maybe that was the reason behind his current behavior.

“Yes, thank you. Sincerely.”

He beamed and took the doll. He tightly hugged it to relieve his mother, trying to compensate for the hugs his biological mother missed out on because of his immaturity. Just like that, escorted by the baron couple, Lloyd left the fiefdom. Up until this point, nobody knew. Lloyd was simply heading to the commerce city to dispose of the old treasures. Nobody saw the future wherein the noble young master and knight of this rural province would accomplish something legendary in Cremo, the city of commerce.

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Chapter 62: Erecting the Statue (2)

“Whew... So this is Cremo.”

Lloyd, standing on the hill, sighed, and a cold air puffed out of his mouth as he exhaled. The air immediately dissipated as it appeared. Before he knew it, winter was creeping near already. The city that stood tall and thick against the blanket of the gray sea came into Lloyd’s view.

This world also has some great cities.

That was the review of Cremo, the city of commerce. To be honest, Lloyd had been skeptical about the size of the city. He didn’t think it could be very big. He had a hazy idea that the cities here wouldn’t be comparable to the modern cities in South Korea, and even if they were big, they would be the size of small cities in the province.

However, that proved to be wrong.

Now that I’m here, I can see it’s bigger than expected.

Of course, the city didn’t have any skyscrapers like Seoul and Busan. Most of the buildings were two-stories tall, and the large ones were three or four-stories tall. Despite that, the size of the city was impressively large.

This place feels like Busan during the Middle Ages.

The hill overlooked the vast shore. The city was formed along the coastline, and a group of sailboats went in and out of the pier on the shore. The workers busily working around the pier resembled a colony of ants, and surely, the size and vitality reflected the city’s location at the center of the province.

And I was able to learn some quite useful skills on our way here.

He suddenly recalled his journey after departing the Frontera barony.

* * *

“Hey, Javier?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“Teach me how to ride a horse.”

It was three mornings after they set off on the journey to Cremo. Lloyd, who had been goofing around in the carriage, spoke to Javier. He thought that it’d be good to learn the skill since he was traveling anyway. Besides, he was getting unbearably bored of dozing off in the carriage.

Not to mention, it’s so burdensome to ride behind Javier every time I ride the horse.

In fact, Lloyd didn’t know how to ride the horse. Suho Kim of South Korea and Lloyd Frontera, the owner of this body, didn’t know a thing about horse riding.

The reason was simple

.

Lloyd chose to drink and party over learning how to ride a horse.

However, he coincidentally received a chance to travel afar. It was the perfect opportunity to learn the skill.

“So teach me horse riding. How about it?”

“Yes, Young Master.”

Javier nodded. Lloyd cocked his head to the side.

“Huh...? Why are you agreeing?”

“Is there a reason for me to deny your request?”

“No, there isn’t. But why are you being so complaisant?”

“Javier, is that you? You’re not him, are you? Tell me honestly. Where is Javier? Where did you hide him?”

“Do you not want to learn how to ride a horse?”

“Tsk. You are such a buzzkill.”

“I do not want to exchange jokes with you, Master Lloyd.”

“How much?”

“I’d rather scrape the dirt off my foot and eat it.”

“Wow.”

Lloyd wondered if he truly hated it to that extent, but his words betrayed his face, which had a faint smile.

“Then come over here. Before we get started, I will teach you the basics of horseback riding.”

That was how Lloyd started to take horseback riding lessons with Javier. Their journey was slow but steady. Winter came closer with each passing day. As the wind blew colder, Lloyd’s riding posture stabilized.

The better he became at horseback riding, the closer he got to Cremo city. And today at last...The delegation safely arrived at Cremo after enduring fifteen days of the cold and bitter winter wind.

“Now, let’s find a place to rest,” instructed Lloyd.

They went down the hill and entered the city. Just like its name as the city of commerce, the roads were wide and crowded. People from all over the region bustled through the streets as carriages and humans passed alongside each other. Merchants and customers yelled at each other to settle on a price. Beads of sweat streaked down the faces of the porters, who were flushed red. The streets rippled with a wave of people moving through the

crowd, and everyone shouted from all directions. The City of Cremo was a chaotic mixture reminiscent of bibimbap. The sight dazed everyone in the delegation. The twenty civil engineers became dumbfounded and speechless as they experienced their first encounter with a bustling metropolis like Cremo. The same went for Javier. No, in his case, it was worse for him.

His eyes constantly scanned around the area nonstop. He strove to take in all the sounds that came around him. The sword master's position an arm's reach from him, Javier's senses were incredibly sensitive even giving him insomnia. When the man was thrown into the congested streets, his senses became overwhelmed. He felt the congestion clearer and more vividly than anyone else in the area. Lloyd's wry smile became just as wide.

"Hey," called Lloyd.

"Yes, Master Lloyd."

"Loosen up."

"I am loosened up."

"It doesn't look like it."

"I really am."

"Then why do your eyes keep rolling to the sides?"

"Excuse me?"

"You're practically scanning the entire area right now. It's like you're in the middle of a war."

Javier flinched but remained silent.

Me? I was that tense?

Lloyd continued to speak.

“I understand this is your first time in such a chaotic place, but can you please be a little more natural? It’s so obvious you’re a country bumpkin.”

“Don’t just stand there. Let’s go.”

Lloyd tapped Javier on the shoulder. Javier followed, a little bit confused.

“Master Lloyd.”

“Yeah.”

“Are you okay, Master Lloyd?”

“Me? What do you mean?”

“I am asking if you are not feeling overwhelmed by the chaos.”

“Yeah. I’m fine. This place isn’t too crowded.”

Lloyd let out a chuckle. It was true, compared to his old home country, South Korea, the congestion of this city felt like nothing.

If you think about the rush hour in Sindorim station, well, this place feels like a peaceful park.

Sindorim station produced an infinite number of human sandwiches as passengers constantly flooded in and out of the train. Anybody could get a free taste of someone’s armpit as it rushed toward their mouth. Everyone was indiscriminately shoved against each other by force. Sindorim Station during rush hour was a hellish place. Lloyd had a plethora of experiences with the chaos and congestion of the Sindorim Station. He was a veteran there.

I had to ride from the Sindorim Station if I wanted to get home from school. Oh, my eventful past.

Lloyd put away his memories as if he were bestowing a medal on his old self. He tactfully led the delegation, which was left half-dazed by the congestion.

“Stop spacing out everyone, and come over here.”

They moved to one side of the bustling road. By asking the merchants for directions, they were able to find a decent inn without wandering around for long. Lloyd then lightly unpacked and cleaned himself. Afterward, he took Javier with him to the center of the city. They moved toward the large mansion that stood tall above the others. It was the manor of Count Cremo, the great lord of the Cremona province and the owner of this very city.

He is also my kind customer who will buy all of the treasures I brought today.

Whatever the case was, the purpose of coming to this place rested on selling the treasures from the orc tribe to help pay off their debt. Thankfully, getting into the count’s mansion was easy.

“I am Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of Baron Frontera. I am here to show you the items you have expressed your desire to purchase via letter.”

He showed the necklace, which was engraved with a symbol of the Frontera barony. It was also the identification that proved his membership in the noble family. Just like that, Lloyd passed through the gate. Past the vast stadium-sized garden, he walked into the main building of the estate.

It’s gigantic.

The mansion undoubtedly had the size befitting its status. It couldn’t be compared to the one in the Frontera barony, which just barely passed as a mansion. This, on the other hand, was the type of estate owned by Hollywood celebrities shown on TV, or closer to the elegant mansions that belonged to the European nobles. That was the kind of mansion Lloyd and Javier were standing before.

“The count is currently at the parlor. Please follow me.”

The old man, who looked like the butler of the mansion, led the way from the main building gate. Lloyd walked around, guided by the old man. The butler began to speak.

“It must have been a long journey from the Frontera barony. Given your distance from the city, allow me to share with you some special precautions as you may not know the count’s current situation.”

“Precautions?” asked Lloyd.

The butler spoke as he continued walking. “The count’s spirit is not very well these days. Therefore, when you meet him, I ask you to keep the conversation to the minimum outside of formalities.”

“Do you mean I should speak only what is necessary?”

“Yes. For there is no need to utter something unnecessary and be nitpicked for your words.”

“Is that how disturbed he is?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Excuse me, if it is not too much, may I know why?” asked Lloyd carefully.

The count was the most powerful man in this province. What would happen if Lloyd made a mistake in front of him and he got on the count’s bad side? The consequences would be devastating and Lloyd didn’t want that to happen. Thus, it would be best if he acted carefully. To Lloyd’s relief, the butler explained without putting up a fight as if he understood where Lloyd was coming from.

“It is because of the series of delayed constructions.”

“Construction delays? What do you mean?”

“The count is currently pushing ahead with the installation of the statue in the sea, but things have been slowing down lately.”

“Installation of the statue...”

Oh, I know. The reason the count decided to purchase my second treasures in the first place was to get cheap jewels to adorn the statue with.

“Things are slowing down, I see. But what is behind the delay?”

“No developer is coming forth to lead the construction.”

The butler continued to explain.

“From the very beginning, the count has always planned on erecting a giant mermaid statue on the shore. It was the solution to a long-standing problem of ours.”

“A long-standing problem?”

“Gigatitan.”

“Oh.” Lloyd nodded.

Lloyd recalled something when he heard the name.

Gigatitan is, as far as I can remember, a giant monster that looks like a lobster.

In *The Knight of Blood and Iron*, the monster was described as having a 295-foot-long body and a shell so hard and thick that no cannons from the warships could penetrate into it.

It’s normally known to reside in the deep sea, but I remember, this city was an exception.

The only exception, actually. It must have been about ten years ago. One Gigatian appeared in the sea of the peaceful Cremo port. It instantly demolished two passing merchant ships. Because of that...

“The count requested help from the Royal Navy. His Majesty accepted it right away as soon as he realized the gravity of the situation. The navy fleet confidently took off to take care of the giant monster.”

The butler continued to explain.

“However, all three attempts to kill the creature failed. It was so because there was no means even for the navy to lay an attack on the Gigatian in the water. In fact, the navy turned back home after losing three ships.”

The old man’s explanation was the same as described in the novel. Lloyd nodded in understanding.

Afterward, the Gigatitan goes to inhabit the coast of Cremo. The Royal Navy decides to wait and see, and the count has no choice but to accept the fate of uncomfortable co-existence with the giant monster.

Thankfully, however, the monster appeared only about three or four times a year, and it never attacked the city on land. That was what made it possible for the city to bear the discomfort of living with the monster. The city then made observation posts across the nearby coasts. They were meant to observe the emergence of the Gigatitan. The observation posts used beacon fires and reflectors when they noticed the emergence of the monster. Once the news was received, the port issued an escape order to all the ships on the coast. When that happened, the ships sailed far away into the sea. Thanks to such an alert system, there were only a few instances of ships getting wrecked in the decade following the monster’s first emergence.

As such, the palace entirely scrapped its plan to kill the monster. There was only one reason. The loss that would be incurred during the process of killing the monster looked to be greater than the loss in continuing their uncomfortable co-existence with the monster.

In fact, their evaluation was spot on. It certainly was the case overall. Losing one or two ships intermittently proved to be less damage than deploying a massive number of navy capabilities to the monster. However, Count Cremo begged to differ.

“And just like that, it has been ten years since we last decided to coexist with the monster. We have since seen a forty percent reduction in trade.”

The butler sighed at length. Lloyd nodded in understanding.

He’s right. Ten years later, the city will be overshadowed by another port for its role in commerce.

This was all because of the Gigatitan. It didn’t cause any immediate damage in the moment, but it was a disaster that was waiting to blow up at any time. From the merchants’ shoes, that alone was risk enough of losing a ship.

I think that’s why they all went away to use other ports.

That was likely why the count decided to put up the statue. It was his way of going against the Gigatitan. Lloyd cocked his head to the side. “So, will erecting the mermaid statue drive away the Gigatitan?”

“Yes, it is likely,” the butler nodded as if it was obvious.

“This is not a simple myth. The mermaids are the most powerful tribe in the sea.”

“Ah, I am already aware of that.”

It was the indisputable truth. In the background of *The Knight of Blood and Iron*, the mermaids in this world were truly powerful. They weren’t the same as the weak and frail creatures who sang songs under the sea in cartoons. They were so muscular and strong that swimmers with Olympic gold medals looked like a child compared to them. Their shoulders were as wide as the Pacific. Their pecs looked firm enough to bounce off flying meteors. They had prominent six-pack abs. Their thick veins look like worms. Literally speaking, they were unrivaled swimmers who spent their whole lives doing hardcore, extreme training. If the orcs were the buff tribe on land, it was the mermaids in the sea.

“Does it mean that you can receive help from the mermaids if you put up the statue?” asked Lloyd.

“We will not be receiving the help, but we can scare the monster.”

“Scare the monster?”

“Yes. Sometimes, the mermaids form a giant army and hunt down the Gigatitan.”

“Aha. So you mean that putting up a giant version of the mermaid would discourage the monster as it will be led to think that it has met its nemesis.”

“That is right. It may possibly go somewhere else once it feels threatened.”

“Hmm, that does make sense.”

This wasn’t a surefire method, but it did hold some potential. The count must have thought that alone was reason enough to erect a mermaid statue.

“But did you say that there are no developers? That is a little strange.”

It indeed was strange. The count was pushing ahead with the construction for the prosperity of the city. The compensation would certainly be massive, so why did no one step forward to take the job? With a short sigh, the butler explained and answered Lloyd’s curiosity.

“The required construction is extremely difficult and esoteric. No, it is almost impossible.”

“How so?”

“What do you think is necessary to put up a statue in the sea?”

“Of course,” said Lloyd, “you need firm ground.”

“Yes, that is right. But the count has added a condition in constructing the foundation.”

“What was it?”

“He wants the ground the statue will be on to be vertically stacked to the surface.”

“Phew.” Lloyd licked his lips in regret.

He finally understood why no developers had volunteered to take the project, and it was because of the statue’s foundation.

An ordinary reclamation method will never satisfy his condition.

Generally, creating land on top of the sea required a ginormous amount of soil to be poured into it. That would cause the ocean floor to become the shape of a pyramid.

However, the count raised opposition to this common method. He had set this ridiculous condition for the construction, but this term was just one of his desperate attempts. Lloyd was able to guess somewhat why the count made such a condition.

“Did he put such a condition because he didn’t want the construction to interfere with the navigation of the ships?”

“Is that your guess?”

“Yes, though simply put.”

The butler widened his eyes when Lloyd asked the question. Lloyd silently put a smile on his face.

Yes, this port didn’t have a wide waterway at the entrance.

He recalled the geography of the shore on his way here. It was sunk in the shape of a half-moon. Compared to the size of the natural port, this one didn’t have a wide waterway.

That must have been the reason why the count flustered everyone by setting such a peculiar condition for construction.

The waterways are already narrow enough, it’ll get even more difficult when the reclamation process narrows it further. The water level around the reclaimed land would become seriously shallow.

The current waterway was extremely narrow, and it was going to get narrower. That would affect the navigation of the ships, and if they were

struck with bad luck, they'd be stranded or crash. One wrong decision to drive out the Gigatitan could blow up into a ludicrous disaster if the waterway got narrowed and became avoided by everyone.

But it's not like the statue can be put up far into the sea. The water would be too deep in the first place to start construction if that's the case.

Lloyd could see the dilemma the count was going through as he tried to put up the statue to drive away the Gigatitan and preserve the waterway.

"Can't it be built on land? There seems to be enough space beside the port."

"That will be difficult."

The butler made a bitter smile at Lloyd's question.

"It must be erected on top of water. Do you think the Gigatitan will fear a mermaid resting on land? The mermaid had to be in the water or at least in shallow waters. That was how the mermaid would look real and threatening to the Gigatitan."

"Aha."

So that's why they're trying to build it in the sea instead of comfortably on the land.

However, the construction was not going as well as he thought it would go. Lloyd understood at last why the count was in a bad mood.

"Anyway, this is the reason why no developers have come forth to start the construction for several months now."

Before Lloyd knew it, he was already in front of the parlor. The butler stopped in the hallway and turned around to face Lloyd. His gaze was serious, and his voice sounded firm.

"You will now be meeting the count. So, make sure to refrain from making any unnecessary remarks. In particular, be careful that you do not mention the words 'Gigatitan,' 'statue,' 'construction,' etc. Please keep my advice in

mind. I answered all your questions to make sure that we are on the same page. Do you understand, Young Master?”

“Yes, I will keep it in mind.”

Lloyd nodded with a sincere expression on his face. The butler smiled in satisfaction and knocked on the door.

“Thank you for understanding. Well then.”

At last, a clear ring of a bell signaled them to come inside. The butler opened the door, and he elegantly motioned his hand. Lloyd entered the parlor guided by the butler. A middle-aged man with a strong build stood inside the parlor. He looked highly dignified and was dressed luxuriously. He was Count Cremo. Lloyd bowed in respect as soon as he saw the count.

Recalling the very words the butler had said a while ago, Lloyd courteously introduced himself, saying, “I, Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera family, am honored to be in your presence to be given the opportunity to suggest a new ‘construction’ method for building the foundation where the ‘statue’ will be put up to drive the ‘Gigatitan’ away.”

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Chapter 63: The Impossible Construction (1)

“I, Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera family, am honored to be in your presence to be given the opportunity to suggest a new ‘construction’ method for building the foundation where the ‘statue’ will be put up to drive the ‘Gigatitan’ away.”

As soon as Lloyd’s voice filled up the parlor, the room instantly sank into silence. The butler who opened the door for Lloyd turned pale. Javier’s brow twitched as he stood behind Lloyd.

Count Cremo, the one who turned to face Lloyd, was...

“Young man, what did you just say?”

He tilted his head.

It worked. He didn’t get angry. I have his attention.

Lloyd, who had spoken such drastic words for that very purpose, immediately replied.

“I mean every word, Your Excellency. Coincidentally, I heard about your concern on the way here, and I realized that I have the solution.”

“Continue speaking,” said the count as he slouched into the parlor chair and looked at him with a sharpened gaze.

It feels like I’m presenting a group project before the professor.

Lloyd, however, didn’t tense up. He suddenly grew oblivious to the count’s status and power. He then considered the count as only one thing.

That man is money. He’s a client who will open his wallet for me.

Lloyd had to figure out a way to win over the client. He had to come up with a method that would prompt his client to sign a contract with him. Like

a chef looking at a dish of his ingredients, Lloyd resolved in his heart and spoke casually.

“To put it bluntly, the current developers don’t have the correct reclamation technique to meet your demand to vertically raise the foundation.”

“Are you saying that it is impossible for them?” asked the count.

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“But it is possible for you?”

“Yes, Your Excellency,” said Lloyd and nodded his head.

In moments like these, showing confidence was essential.

So, Lloyd continued, his voice filled with conviction.

“In order to make a great, solid foundation with the little land mass in the narrow waterway, I must combine the friction pile and Box Caisson method, Your Excellency.”

“Pile? Box Caisson?” repeated the count.

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“Hmm, it sounds fine.”

“Your Excellency, are you familiar with those methods, by any chance?” asked Lloyd in surprise.

“No, not at all.”

The count shook his head. He grinned like a huge bear.

“How should I know them?”

“If that is the case...”

“No one was willing to take the construction anyway,” explained the count, “Yet that pesky monster Gigantitan continues to stick around the coast, and my port is continually losing trade deals because of it. Here you are brimming with confidence, so I am entrusting it to you. If you succeed, good. If you fail, I still have nothing to lose. Oh, but you do know that if your construction fails, you will have to shoulder the cost of the construction, yes?”

“Of course.”

In the case Lloyd succeeded, he was set to make an obscene amount of money. Not to mention he could potentially grow close with Count Cremo, the most powerful man in the province. This meant that Lloyd would be getting reliable supporters.

Just perfect.

Lloyd discretely clenched his fists.

I just devised a plan when I heard the predicament from the butler, and it worked like a charm.

The construction was on a halt, and no builder was coming out to take the job. That was where Lloyd smelled money. The smell was thick, like a cup of espresso. So he racked his brain during the short walk to the parlor. He calculated the chances of the construction ending in success the benefits he would be attaining and the loss should it come to failure.

Lloyd included all the potential factors in his calculation. Once that was done, he quickly drew a conclusion: It was worth taking the challenge. On top of his mental calculation, he remembered the part in the novel that talked about what the count was like.

He’s a man with machismo and who isn’t afraid to take on challenges. He thinks highly of capable people, and he doesn’t allow himself to be restricted by superfluous formalities.

The count didn’t care what people were like as long they were skilled. That was why he treated Javier with respect in the novel, even when the latter was a wanted man. Even in the middle of the story, he still became a reliable supporter of Javier.

The count must be the same now.

That was why Lloyd opted to be direct and straightforward instead of beating around the bush. He had informed the count that he had a solution and drew his attention. Now, Lloyd’s attempt worked wonders.

Lloyd said, “Thank you for trusting me, Your Excellency.”

“Do not thank me. By the way, I didn’t hear everything because you jumped right into talking about the construction. Who did you say you were?”

“Oh, I am Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera family.”

Lloyd bowed in respect. At that moment, the warm smile on the count’s face disappeared.

His face looked way worse than when Lloyd tossed the words “Gigatitan,” “statue,” and “construction” as he ignored the butler’s advice.

“What an insolent prick you are.”

Count Cremo rose from his seat with a straight face and trudged toward Lloyd’s way. He brushed past Lloyd, stopping instead right in front of Javier, the count harshly glared down at the knight in front of him.

“Yes, I knew you seemed awfully confident while speaking about this fascinating construction technique for some reason. You are the infamous eldest son of the Frontera family. I have heard quite often about your excellent construction skills these days. In fact, I even thought about sending a man to commission you for the project. However, I have never imagined you to be this bold and show such disregard for manners.”

The count’s voice turned rougher.

“I let it slide when your subject spoke on your behalf in regard to the construction. How dare you have him pay his respect to me instead of facing me directly and formally introducing yourself? Ha! I have never fathomed that I would live to see such impertinence.”

Anger flooded through the count, which was evident in his eyes. Just behind him was Lloyd, who was left feeling embarrassed and awkward. He found himself scratching his chin.

“Uhm, Count Cremo?”

“Subject! Do not speak anymore and stay quiet!” bawled the count without turning back.

“Now, do explain, the eldest son of the Frontera family. Did you come here to be rude to me today?”

The stern gaze of the count’s face pierced into Javier’s placid face. Lloyd chuckled in sadness.

“Uhm, Count Cremo?”

“Did I not tell you to stay quiet?” his voice sounded sterner.

“Uhm, I am sorry, but—”

“If you are sorry, shut—”

“I am Lloyd Frontera,” interrupted Lloyd.

“Hmm?”

Count Cremo froze and finally, he turned awkwardly and faced Lloyd again.

“You are?” asked the count.

“Yes,” replied Lloyd.

“You are the eldest son in the Frontera family?”

“Yes.”

A wry smile was formed on Lloyd’s face. With a confused face, Count Cremo pointed at Javier.

“What about this fellow?”

“He is my personal knight,” answered Lloyd.

“Really?”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“Really?”

“Yes, really.”

“Hmm. But this fellow over here has the appearance of a noble, not you.”

Lloyd didn’t know what to say.

“I’m not lying,” pressed Count Cremo one more time.

“Well, anyway. I am glad to meet such a skilled and famous developer as yourself.”

“Yes...I am honored.”

Once they settled into their seats after a handshake, the count let out a loud chuckle. He gazed at Lloyd with eyes full of fascination.

“You must be a fairly wise man,” said the count.

“Excuse me?”

“I mean that you are magnanimous and generous.”

“I do not know what you mean.”

A wise man? Magnanimous?

Those words puzzled Lloyd. With another burst of laughter, the count spoke. “I’m saying this because you let such a handsome knight who looks more noble than you stand by your side. Go and ask anyone you meet for the first time. Ask a hundred people, and every single one of them will think that fellow is the noble, and you are his subject.”

“Eek.”

“Why? Do you believe otherwise?”

“No, Your Excellency. It’s just you’re very direct with your words.”

“Hahaha. You know the truth as well, and yet, you still have him beside you so casually. My, you are a man of character, indeed.”

Can we please get back to talking about the construction now? Lloyd wished in his heart. Thankfully, the count’s verbal attacks stopped there.

“Shall we continue talking about where we left off about the construction?”

“Yes, thank you.”

After that, Lloyd was able to turn the topic and discuss constructing the foundation under the sea. Most part of the discussion revolved around Lloyd explaining to the count the technicalities of the construction, and the latter simply nodded. The count promised to provide Lloyd with laborers, to which Lloyd expressed his gratitude. With that, the construction contract was signed. The very purpose of traveling all the way to the city, selling secondhand treasures, was achieved without any problem as well.

“Hand the items over to the butler, and get the payment from him as well,” instructed the count.

“Thank you.”

“No need to thank me. Please make sure that the construction ends in success. If you do, I will make sure to reward you with a hefty sum.”

“I will keep that in mind, Your Excellency.”

Treat clients with your utmost courtesy. Recalling this principle, Lloyd sincerely conveyed his appreciation to the count. A long time ago Lloyd had suggested building a heated flooring system to the pub owner. That day was his first day in this world, and he came up with a grand vision for the future. His bold future vision was that he would someday be commissioned with a large-scale civil engineering project and build ports and bridges to pay off the crushing debt that weighed heavily on the baron family. Now, that determination was slowly turning into reality. This marked the first construction contract from an upper-class noble and the beginning of a new construction that would earn him thick stacks of cash.

* * *

The following morning rolled around. Lloyd began preparing for the construction to lay the artificial ground under the sea. It was time to survey.

“Hmph.”

Waves of the coast splashed against the port. Lloyd and Javier were on a hard wooden boat on the sea. Lloyd struck his head out its ledge and drew in a heavy breath. He put on a pair of goggles that looked like a large soap case. He held his breath and leaned forward, putting his head into the sea. The seawater felt cold against his face.

Ugh... It feels like my face is being torn off.

It was early winter. So, when he dove his unprotected face into the water, it felt like his skin was being ripped away from him.

Lloyd didn’t pull his face out. He couldn’t because he had to survey.

No construction can take place without surveying. In order for me to activate the skill, I need to “see” the site with my own eyes.

The construction for this project would take place at the bottom of the sea. This meant that he had to directly see the seabed.

Thankfully, the water is clear.

Lloyd snapped open his eyes under the cold water. The turbidity of the shore in Cremo City was low. This meant that the water was pristine, almost transparent, with extremely few sediments floating around. On top of that, the goggles the count provided were pretty decent. Thanks to all of these factors, Lloyd could get a somewhat clear view of the seabed almost thirty-two feet away.

The surveying skill activated and informed Lloyd about the information on the seabed.

I'm relieved that the slope is almost nonexistent at the bottom. It's flat. Plus, the surface of the bottom is rich with a sedimentary layer and is adequately soft. As for the weathered rock layer and soft rock layer... Hmm. I don't see the latter.

The soft rock layer referred to the comparatively solid ground far under the surface of the seabed.

Lloyd could not see it down under. To be more correct, Lloyd could not detect the soft rock layer within the sixteen feet of the ground he could see using the Subterranean Scanning skill.

It'd probably be deeper down. But it doesn't matter. Anyway... Argh...I've reached my limit.

Lloyd grimaced as he surveyed the sea. Was it because he couldn't hold his breathing any longer? No, it was because of the icy water. It felt like his face was vanishing. At last, Lloyd jerked his head out of the water, unable to endure any longer.

"Phew! Huff, huff! Towel!"

Lloyd shouted the moment he got out. A towel was immediately handed to him.

“Here it is.”

Javier held out a plushy towel. Lloyd removed the goggles and took the towel. He then wiped the seawater off his face. It was much later when the senses in his skin started to come back.

Ugh. I hate it. I hate it so much.

Holding his breath was bearable but the seawater was too cold. He feared that he’d get frostbite. As the self-deprecation began to eat him up inside, Lloyd stared at Javier.

“Hey.”

“Yes?”

“Can’t you do the surveying for me?”

Lloyd meant every word he said. If he could, he wanted to pass the buck to Javier, but Lloyd himself and Javier knew very well that it couldn’t be passed.

“Of course, I wish to do it for you, but-”

“But?”

“I don’t want to.”

“Why?” asked Lloyd.

“I am enjoying how things are now.”

“Enjoying it? Wait, you...” Lloyd trailed off.

“Yes, I am extremely elated to see you struggle through your efforts.”

“Hey...”

“I am joking.”

“Ha... I didn’t know you knew how to joke.”

“I am very happy right now unlike usual.”

“Because you can see me struggling and scuffling around?”

“Yes.”

“That, of course, was a joke too.”

This punk is having too much fun.

However, on the other hand, Lloyd could feel something else. He could feel that Javier wasn’t blindly enjoying this situation very much.

“Anyway, do you think it will work out this time, too?” asked Javier.

“Work out? What do you mean?”

“The construction.”

The way Javier said it was full of concern.

“To be honest, I cannot imagine what it will look like in the slightest.”

“Imagine?”

“Yes.”

Javier continued to explain.

“The water is not very shallow down here. So it makes me wonder if it is indeed possible for anyone to make land without pouring soil and rocks over it.”

“Are you skeptical?”

“Yes, this place is entirely different from the Maritz Wetland.”

Those were Javier’s honest thoughts. The Maritz Wetland was drained of water and turned into farmland. However, this sea was poles apart from that place.

“I also wonder if you plan on having Hamang drink the seawater. But, even then, it still looks impossible,” said Javier again, his voice dripping with doubt.

Even if Hamang could drink buckets of seawater, it barely changed anything. After all, the sea held an unimaginable amount of water. Hamang could endlessly drink without stopping, but the water would never drain. So, the method they used for the Martiz Wetland was impossible here.

With sincerity, Javier asked, “Master Lloyd, do you have any magic in place, by any chance?”

He asked because this project seemed impossible without the help of magic. Javier heard the various methods Lloyd enumerated to the count, but it was all still a mystery. Since Lloyd understood where Javier was coming from, he shrugged.

“Magic, you say. It’s similar,” said Lloyd.

It was indeed similar. Something magical was brewing up. So it was natural for Javier to be curious. Thinking that in his head, Lloyd spoke to Javier.

“This time, we are going to use the most magical ingredient in construction fields.”

“Magical ingredient? What do you mean?”

“Have you ever heard of cement?”

Lloyd grinned softly as he said the ingredient out loud. He thought to himself, *Yes, indeed. Construction sites are nothing without concrete.*

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Chapter 64: The Impossible Construction (2)

Cement was a mixture that was used in putting up buildings and was an indispensable ingredient for construction.

“The word comes from the Latin word, ‘cementum,’ which means ‘small broken rocks’.”

“Latin...?”

“Oh, yes, there is a language that’s called Latin,” added Lloyd.

“Is that an ancient language?”

“You’re right.” Lloyd nodded his head. He chuckled as he stared at Javier rowing the boat.

“Anyway, I am thinking of making cement from now on. Without it, this project isn’t going to go anywhere.”

“So you mean there is no magical power involved then,” said Javier.

“Of course. We can’t go under because of this one project,” said Lloyd straightforwardly.

What he said was true. Magicians were highly valuable. It wasn’t anything surprising that they were obscenely expensive. If there was a magician that held enough power to materially impact large-scale constructions...

They would be more expensive. I could scrap every penny of my fiefdom’s budget, and it still wouldn’t be enough to cover them. After all, they would be on the same level as the kingdom’s senior magicians.

It was impossible to mobilize a magician for this project. Lloyd never even considered hiring them in the first place. He continued to speak. “We don’t need magic. Thankfully, the survey back there confirmed that my technique will work.”

“Do you mean...the friction pile or whatever?”

“Yeah,” Lloyd said as he nodded.

Just as he said, this technique seemed to be the perfect fit for this part of the sea. It was more so because there was a soft rock layer deeply buried beneath the seabed.

It’s just like the bottom of countless buildings built around the great canal Canal Grande in Venice.

The foundation of the Venice buildings Lloyd had come across in his club years came to his mind. Venice was a city built on water, and its foundation was pretty similar to this place. A thick mudflat and mud covered the seabed, and a soft rock layer sat much further below it.

It was so deep that the base of a typical building wouldn’t be able to reach it. Amid such circumstances, the people of Venice came up with a wise solution.

They stuck dozens, hundreds, and thousands of long piles under the seabed. Once the piles were solidified in the mud, they worked to build the foundation of buildings on them.

Fast forward hundreds of years. Those ever-sturdy piles supported the buildings just fine.

This was the traditional method of friction pile.

Of course, the technique got developed in the modern days.

The fundamental principle remained almost unchanged. The only change was the replacement of materials. From the wooden piles, they were changed to larger and sturdier ones, such as concrete pillars or H-beams. Lloyd mapped out one more technique used in the modern days on top of the friction pile method.

“I will be mixing the friction pile and box caisson method together since the water here is deeper than in Venice. The mudflat and mud layer in this place

is thicker and softer, so it’s perfect for the caisson to be sunk by its own weight.”

Javier simply sat staring at Lloyd without saying anything.

“Not a clue what I am talking about, eh?” asked Lloyd.

“No.”

“Well, anyway, if I want the box caisson to be a success, I must make cement. All right, let’s go.”

Before they realized it, the boat was already touching the pier.

The two of them walked out of the boat and got to the pier when a soft voice welcomed their arrival.

“You are here.”

A velvety and gentle voice.

The owner of the voice warmly greeted them with crinkled eyes. There was also a light pink flush on her cheeks. A beautiful young lady was standing on the pier. She was looking at them as she greeted them with a sheepish look.

“Hmm?” Lloyd cocked his head to the side.

He had no memory of her. It was his first time meeting her, but her dress wasn’t anything ordinary. She was donned in an extremely luxurious dress, which stood in stark contrast with the gloomy pier. Moreover, the people she was surrounded by sharpened the contrast all the more. Five knights clad in silver armor protected her side.

“Excuse me, may I ask who you are?” asked Lloyd.

She was definitely not a commoner. Lloyd’s careful question was received with silence.

That was because she wasn’t smiling at Lloyd. She was smiling at Javier.

“Although I am overcome with shyness to say this, I have been waiting for you, Sir Asrahan.”

“Waiting for me?” asked Javier.

“Yes. And this...please take this.”

The lady hung her head as her cheeks flushed in a pinkish red.

She then held out something tightly grasped in her hands.

“I sincerely hope you will take it.”

Lloyd vividly recognized what it was. It was a letter in a light pink envelope. Even more, the letter was signed beautifully with the name “Christine Cremo.”

Hold on. Christine Cremo...? The only daughter of Count Cremo? She came down here all of a sudden to give a letter to Javier?

This was a monumentally ridiculous situation for Lloyd. On the other hand, Javier was...

“Thank you, my lady.”

He took the letter casually and put it inside his pocket like a seasoned lover.

He looked natural and casual, as if he had experienced this many times. The sight made Lady Christine blush furthermore. She whipped around as if she couldn’t take the embarrassment welling up in her. She quickly walked ahead, almost running away, and distanced herself from the pier. The knights were taken aback by her sudden behavior, so they followed suit in a quick manner.

Now, Lloyd and Javier were the only ones left on the pier. The sea wind swished around them.

“Hey.”

Lloyd broke the silence first.

“What in the world just happened?”

“It looks like I have received a letter,” Javier deadpanned.

“Yeah, I know that part. I am asking why you are receiving a letter.”

“It appears it is because of what happened as we departed the count’s manor yesterday.”

“Yesterday? Did something happen when we went out of the manor?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“What happened?”

Lloyd tilted his head to the side.

Nothing had happened the day before. He simply met the count, proposed a new plan, and signed the contract. Afterward, he handed over the secondhand treasures to the butler. Once they were appraised and appropriated for their value, Lloyd was given a satisfying sum of gold coins. That was all that happened. It was the version of events Lloyd remembered about the previous day. But Javier’s version was slightly different.

“It was around the time we walked out of the mansion after receiving the payment from the butler. At that time...”

“At that time? What?” Lloyd said impatiently.

“That lady was strolling around the garden when she turned around to our side. Our eyes locked at that moment for a second.”

“So?” Lloyd asked.

“That is all,” said Javier.

“Hold on... Your eyes locked with hers for a moment, and that was all? The next day, that noble lady hands you a letter with a blushing face? Do you really see nothing strange about this situation? Really?”

“Yes.”

“How so?”

“What do you mean, how so?” Javier looked at Lloyd and cocked his head.

It was as if he couldn’t understand the fuss behind something so natural. And, his words reflected his attitude the same.

“Our eyes were locked,” Javier said.

Lloyd was lost for words.

“Master Lloyd, has this never happened to you before?”

“I have no words.”

“The number of love letters I have received like that... Let me count,” said Javier.

“Don’t count.”

“Forty... Fifty... One hundred... 150... Hmm...”

“I said don’t count.”

“It appears I have about 537 letters, including the one I just received.

Lloyd hated handsome bastards for this very reason. He was thoroughly annoyed by them.

Dirty and guileful handsome men.

Lloyd let out a scoff. “Let’s drop the subject and get back to where we left off.”

“By where we left off, you mean-”

“Cement.”

Lloyd spoke as he turned to walk toward the inn.

“I will be heading back to the inn. And you should go and meet the butler.”

“What should I tell him?”

“Tell him to send ten kilos each of limestone, sand, and volcanic ash to the inn. Oh, don’t forget to tell him to hook us up to a forge we can borrow as our workshop.”

“I understand. Is that all?”

“No, there’s more,” said Lloyd.

“What is it?”

“Look at the ground when you walk and cover up your face.”

“Excuse me?”

“I am telling you to stop alluring innocent girls, man.”

“Could it be that you are jealous of me?”

“What?”

“I am saying this because it appears that you have been jealous of me since earlier. There’s no other explanation.”

“Haha, no way. No way at all.”

Lloyd shrugged, his attitude relaxed.

“The type of person I look down on the most are those who flirt with any girls they see on the street.”

“Flirt?”

“There’s such a thing. It happened before. So, I was on the street near my school, and a boy walked up to a girl and asked her for directions. The girl shouted, ‘I have a boyfriend!’ and she ran off at lightning speed. Goodness, can you imagine how humiliated he was? It was just so funny looking at it, but goodness, the man felt so embarrassed and hopeless that he couldn’t get a wink of sleep for several nights... Dammit...”

“Oh... This is your story...”

“Haa, if you know, then go.”

“Cheer up.”

“Shut up. Scram.”

“I will be back...”

With that, Javier trodded off to the manor. The items he had asked from the butler arrived at the inn around nighttime. Volcanic ash, however, was excluded from the bundle, and it came with a letter that the ash could not be acquired.

“Tsk.” Lloyd licked his lips in regret.

Volcanic ash. The most crucial ingredient in this project was missing.

I need that to make Greek or Roman-style cement.

He was disappointed. Was he disappointed because he liked Roman-style civil engineering?

No, he was disappointed because there was a clear benefit to using Roman-style cement.

It’s the sturdiest kind among the types of cement I can make now here.

In fact, the history of cement was very deep.

The item held more than 5,000 years of history. This ancient cement was already being used to build pyramids in Egypt around the time Dangun established the Gojoseon. In particular, the cement that boasted the most robustness and reliability was Greek and Roman.

People battered pozzolan cement, sand, and volcanic ash with seawater.

The resulting cement was truly sturdy. It was so sturdy that even the cement breakwaters built over 2,000 years ago stood tall and effective to this day. The secret behind such sturdiness was in the volcanic ash.

It’s thanks to the tuff in the ash. It tightens the space between the aggregate and mortar, and it prevents fissures from spreading in the structure.

So, that was the reason why Lloyd wanted to use Roman cement as much as possible. That was also why he had requested volcanic ash from the butler. However, it didn’t come.

Well, it makes sense. It’s not like there’s a volcano nearby, and no one would think to store it after traveling far away to a volcano. Is Portland cement the only available option for me? That seems like a much harder option.

Portland cement was considered the beginning of modern cement. Lloyd had somewhat of an idea of the manufacturing method.

You crush and dry limestone, clay, silica, and oxidized steel. After that, you filter it with water, bake it after mixing in some coal powder, and once it’s frozen, mix it up with the plaster and disintegrate it.

He only had a general idea of the process. So it looked like he would need to repeatedly experiment until he had the exact formula. From that moment onward, Lloyd engrossed himself in producing cement.

He ground and mixed the ingredients he had gotten from the count. He fired it in the forge and dried it in the early winter sea breeze. Grind, mix, and

pour water. Rinse and repeat. But despite his efforts, he didn’t make any cement.

No. It keeps crumbling to pieces.

The mixture’s ratio of the ingredients might have been incorrect, or there could’ve been a defect in the process of baking or freeze drying the mixture. He didn’t know what the issue was.

The cement looked decent, but it didn’t do its job. It seemed fine when Lloyd mixed the water and sand. But when it was out to dry, a long crack was formed on its surface.

I can’t use this for the project.

Fifteen days passed. As time progressed without any fruitful result, nervousness started to creep into his heart.

I wish I could get my hands on volcanic ash. Then, I wouldn’t even have this worry.

If he had a large amount of volcanic ash, he’d only have to experiment with the proportions of the limestone and sand.

Then, he could produce cement in a much more convenient manner with more satisfying results. He was wistful that it wasn’t the case. At one point, he thought of going to a volcano himself to get the ash.

But...No, no. There’s nowhere near to get volcanic ash, and it would be too inefficient if you consider the loading expenses. Not to mention the time it will take to get there.

It was realistically impossible.

I guess the only available option for me is to bite the bullet and get on with this experiment.

He would succeed eventually if he kept trying. Until then, he would not stop.

With such a resolution in mind, Lloyd threw himself in the experiment, giving up sleep at night. He wasn't getting any good results even as his eyes turned bloodshot with exhaustion. Later, he was so strained that his nose started to bleed.

Drip. "Eh...?"

Lloyd, who was grinding the silica in the corner of the dark forge, stopped what he was doing when something was felt under his nose. He casually brushed his nose with his fingers. Blood was smeared on them.

"Ugh, dammit."

He covered his nose with his sleeve and pressed down. Just then, the current predicament made him think back to his past, and a wry smile naturally formed on his face.

It's just like when I was in Korea.

Back then, he had seven nosebleeds a week. His unignitable spirit wasn't quenched. He convinced himself that tomorrow would be better if he just endured one more day, that the following month would be better if he made it through the next day. He told himself that he'd be able to live just like anybody else and land a secure job and get married and start a loving family.

He pushed through each day with such convictions in mind. It was all thanks to the memories of his past...

Okay, let's try some more. No giving up. I can't give up so easily. Not yet.

Lloyd grabbed the silica once again as he made these resolutions in his heat. Just then, he found a clue to the solution that he had never thought of before.

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Chapter 65: Leveling Up Summon Partners (1)

“Ppodong?”

“Eh...?”

A soft noise came beside him. It was almost a whisper, and it was followed by the sound of something rolling softly.

Lloyd was jostled out of his thoughts. He looked to the side, still pressing his nose against his sleeve.

“Ppodong?” called Lloyd.

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong was standing on top of the work table. He was looking up at Lloyd with his puffed cheeks and dark eyes. He wasn’t alone.

“Bangul!”

“Hamang!”

Behind Ppodong was Bangul, who slithered near Ppodong from the corner of the table. Hamang, not wanting to be left behind alone, rolled and came into Lloyd’s view. They all looked up with their round and dark eyes.

“Hmm? What are you all doing here?” asked Lloyd.

“Ppodong!”

“Bangul!”

“Hamang!”

“What? You want me to play with you?”

“Ppo!”

“Bang!”

“Ha!”

The three creatures stood in one line and nodded with all their might. It was already late into the night, and Lloyd was preoccupied with the experiment. So he was slightly flustered by their sudden demand to play with them.

“Uhm, I’m sorry, but can we play next time?” said Lloyd, apologizing.

“Ppodong?”

“Bangul?”

“Hamamang?”

“Really,” said Lloyd, “I am a bit slammed today. I’ve got a lot to think about and experiment with. I really need to pull this off no matter what.”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“Bba-bangul?”

“Hamang...?”

“I’m sorry. So let’s play another time. Okay? I’m actually working right now even though I have a nosebleed. In all honesty, I just want to put this work behind me and play with you all.”

“Ppodong!”

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

“Hamamang!”

“No, no. I’m not saying that we can rest and play now...”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“I wish I could, but my hands are tied. I’m sorry for getting your hopes up. Truly. So let’s play next time.”

Lloyd smiled, not knowing what to do.

He indeed wanted to rest.

He wanted to go out and play just for a bit.

But that was impossible.

He had confidently told the count that he could do it. He had bragged to the count about his special construction method and how he could use it to erect the statue.

He had put himself in this position by making those grand declarations. However, he was already stuck in the preparation stage. Making cement was much more complicated than he’d thought. He didn’t want to imagine the whole construction ending up in a failure after being unable to overcome this obstacle.

“So, I need to hold on and move forward even if times are tough right now. Don’t worry about me. I can do it. Okay? Let’s have a lot of fun after this project is finished.” Lloyd smiled as he patted his three friends.

They were naturally obedient creatures, so Lloyd thought that this explanation would be sufficient for them. However, that wasn’t the case this time.

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“Bangul!”

“Hamang!”

For some reason, they resisted firmly, and making things worse, they simply lay down in stubbornness and started rolling on Lloyd’s notes where his ideas on the cement mixture were written.

“Ppo-do-do-dong!”

“Bangul! Bba-ba-bangul!”

“Hamamang! Hamang!”

“Eh? You guys?”

Lloyd continued to soothe his friends afterward, hugging, patting, and rocking them in his arms. However, none of it worked. For the first time ever, they completely turned a deaf ear to Lloyd and obstinately demanded to go outside. Their eyes later started to grow moist as they all looked up at Lloyd.

“Ppo-do-dong...”

“Bangul...”

“Hamaaang...”

They were just seconds away from breaking into tears and writhing in sadness. In actuality, these three summons had their own reason for doing this. It wasn’t a simple stubborn and childish tantrum. It was their desire to protect Lloyd. That feeling was what was moving the three of them.

Ppo-do-dong. Ppodong...

Pets noticed what was going on with their owners surprisingly better than the latter thought. There was only one reason behind it. They spent all day looking at their owners. So, these three summons knew Lloyd’s current state better than he knew himself.

Bangul…

They noticed how Lloyd had been pushing himself too much lately for the past few days. They saw how Lloyd hadn’t properly slept for many nights now and how he was preoccupied with the experiment at every waking moment.

Lloyd was overworking himself to the point of exhaustion. It was, in turn, narrowing his view and compromising his ability to think.

Hamang...

So they had to force Lloyd to take a small break. He needed to put down his work and have a change of pace for at least a moment. So that was why they acted more obstinate in resisting Lloyd. They wiggled their butts really hard. They rolled around, whimpering. They licked the back of Lloyd's hand and his cheeks. They wagged their tails and stretched out their short legs. They looked like dogs demanding their owners to take them for a stroll. That was how they appeared in Lloyd's eyes. As he gazed at the three summons, they reminded him of an old fluffy friend in the past.

Gaeul.

Gaeul was his childhood dog. The dog was no longer with him and perhaps that was why he blurted out something he used to say every day to his pet.

"Then shall we go for a walk?"

"Ppodong!"

"Bangul!"

"Hamang!"

The three summon partners nodded their small heads. Ppodong and Hamang high-fived with their short hands in celebration when their operation succeeded. Bangul, who had no hands, joined with her fat tail.

"Goodness, are you guys that happy?"

The sight put a wry smile on his face. Lloyd swooped all of them in his embrace and walked out of the forge and into the dark street.

It's cold.

It was early winter at the pier. The wind was abnormally cold here. Lloyd raised the collars of his coat and looked down.

“Are you all okay?”

“Ppo!” “Bang!” “Ha!”

They answered in unison as they were tucked inside his inner pocket. Lloyd’s wry smile deepened.

“Hey, you three. I don’t think anyone can call this a stroll, don’t you think?”

“Ppo?” “Bang?” “Ha?”

“I’m the one walking, and you all are just being carried by me. Not to mention, for free.”

“Ppo-o?” “Baang?” “Ha-a?”

“Oh, yeah? You’re going to tilt your heads and play dumb, eh? You know you look cute like that. Fine, you are cute. So cute. Haa.”

This is more like I’m being walked by them, not the other way around.

Lloyd found himself letting out a chuckle. The creatures gazed at him with their beady eyes, and they reminded Lloyd once again of his old dog.

Gaeul was just like them.

He was a puppy with white curly fur. A mixed breed of a Poodle and Maltese. The previous owner explained that he was immigrating to the United States, and therefore, could not bring the dog with him. Gaeul was less than a year old when he became Lloyd’s family.

This happened when Lloyd was in middle school. He thought that the puppy would stay by his side forever. Gaeul whimpered and threw tantrums all day, even when he took him out for a stroll and played ball.

It was especially the case when Lloyd studied for an exam. He asked the dog for a raincheck each time it happened. He smiled and refused to take Gaeul out, saying, “Next time.”

He thought that he’d always have the luxury of time, and it would simply remain static and unmoving.

I should have played with him more back then.

He went to high school and entered university. Gaeul grew just as Lloyd did. Before he knew it, Gaeul was already old, and by the time Lloyd got back from the military service, the senile dog had a hard time going out on a stroll.

Even so, Lloyd wasn’t able to pay much attention to him. The shadow of debt hung heavily over his family. It made everyone suffocate and suffer. Their days were tough and hard. Everyone no longer had any time or care to give for the small puppy. On one clear day, when it was as chilly as the early winter of mid-November, Gaeul quietly died in peace.

Lloyd was filled with nothing but regret for not taking care of him.

Shoot. I was trying not to think about him.

He became upset every time he thought about it. So he decided to push away from the memory as much as possible. Brushing off the sudden burst of emotion once again, he walked along the street at night, sometimes blowing his hands against the cold winter and chatting with the three summon creatures in his inner pocket.

Each time he did so, Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang gleamed in his eyes. They smiled in joy as if they were basking in the moment. At that sight, Lloyd thought to himself, and he reflected on his past behavior.

I might have been just taking advantage of them.

Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang had feelings. They could feel emotions. Up until today, he only sought them when needed, treating them as nothing but

tools and construction equipment.

If this continues, it'll be the same as when I said goodbye to Gaeul.

Come to think of it, he realized that he had been acting selfishly. Clenching his fists, he accepted that he did them wrong and decided to do better. He then turned around to get back to the forge when a message appeared in front of him.

Ding dong.

[The summon creatures are acknowledging your sincere feelings.]

[They consider you a part of their family.]

[Your relationship level with these creatures has increased from <Master-Servant Relationship> to <A Member of the Gang>.]

Lloyd never ever expected to receive this type of message. It didn't end just there. Lloyd's eyes moved fast to read more messages.

[A new feature has been activated following the increase in relationship with the summon.]

[<Summon Partner Upgrade> has now opened.]

[<Summon Partner Upgrade> requires 500 RP.]

[<Summon Partner Upgrade> gives a new skill to the creature.]

[Once activated, the <Summon Partner Upgrade> cannot be reversed. Please be discreet when you are making the decision.]

What in the world is this... Wow.

Lloyd's eyes widened.

Upgrading summon partners and new skills?

He had no idea that this could be possible.

Who'd have thought I'd bump into this luck during my stroll with them? Well, it's a blessing in disguise indeed. Some say detours are shortcuts, and indeed they were right. This requires only 500 RP?

Lloyd wondered what kind of skill would come out. Feeling curious and exhilarated, he gazed into his pocket, where the three summons were wriggling inside his pocket.

They were looking at him, so he asked, "Hey, you all."

"Ppodong?"

"Bangul?"

"Hamang?"

"Uhm, did you feel that, too? The message I just read?"

"Ppo!" "Bang!" "Ha!"

The three of them nodded in unison. It dawned on Lloyd that they must know as well that they can be upgraded. Just then, "Bangul! Bba-bangul! Bangul!"

Bangul strangely jumped up and down as she gazed at him with an extra sparkle in her eyes. She was saying that Lloyd must pick her, that she was the one.

She resembled a chirping baby bird with her mouth wide open. There was more.

"Ppodong? Ppo-do-dong!"

"Hamang! Hamamang!"

Ppodong and Hamang lifted Bangul up. They pushed her up like they were raising a trophy as if they were signaling that Lloyd must select her.

Curious, Lloyd asked, “Do you two think that Bangul should be upgraded?”

“Ppo!” “Bang!” “Ha!”

“Wait, can you by any chance feel what kind of skill will come out once you level up?” asked Lloyd.

“Ppo!” “Bang!” “Ha!”

“What? Bangul will be able to help me out big time?”

“Bangul!”

It was Bangul who responded.

“Bangul! Bba-bangul! Bangul!”

“Are you saying that I should just trust you and go, because I wouldn’t lose anything?”

“Bangul!” Bangul excitedly nodded up and down.

Seeing that, Lloyd thought to himself, *Maybe it’s worth putting my hopes in her. She must be this confident for a reason.*

He started to become more convinced. After all, Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang had done nothing but help in a myriad of ways.

They fulfilled their roles at the most needed times. Now, they were confidently recommending Lloyd to upgrade Bangul. Thinking that they must have a reason, Lloyd decided to trust them.

Yeah, I got nothing to lose.

Even though the upgrade required more than 500 RP, he had enough of it.

No, he had more than enough. It was practically overflowing.

Okay, let’s try it out.

If it failed, then he still had nothing to lose. If the skill he needed popped out, then it was a jackpot. Lloyd selected the menu “Summon Partner Upgrade.”

[You are now upgrading a summon partner.]

[Please select the summon partner you wish to upgrade.]

Bangul.

Lloyd placed Bangul on his palm. That was how he chose the creature for this feature.

[The summon partner you have chosen is “Bangul.”]

[The cost of upgrading Bangul: 500 RP]

[Current RP: 2401]

[Would you like to start the upgrade?]

[YES / NO]

Yes.

Lloyd nodded his head.

[Upgrading the summon partner.]

It started from then.

“Bangul?”

Bangul was enveloped in a mysterious, transparent light.

Some seconds later, the message he had waited for appeared.

[You have succeeded in upgrading Bangul.]

[Upgrade level: plus one]

[As a reward, Bangul has received new skills.]

[Bangul’s Skill Log]

[Chomping Dirt (Level three)]

[Accelerated Dirt Digestion (Level three)]

[Steel Dung Launcher (Level five)]

[Volcanic Blast (Level one)]

What...?

Lloyd carefully read through the message, and his gaze reached the last part.

Volcanic Blast?

Lloyd’s eyes widened in surprise as he processed the name of the new skill.

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Chapter 66: Leveling Up Summon Partners (2)

Oh. Volcanic blast?

Lloyd’s eyes trembled. Literally speaking, this meant that the volcano would erupt. No, it meant that Bangul could make the volcano explode.

This can’t be true, can it?

If a volcano erupted as the skill’s name suggested, that would only spell disaster. He feared that it would only become a monumental nuisance to people if that was the case, so it couldn’t be used. Lloyd’s gaze traveled to Bangul.

“Bangul?” called Lloyd.

“Bangul?” Bangul lifted up his head.

Despite the upgrade, she still looked as cute as always. Her beady eyes glimmered, ready to answer any question. Beaming at her, Lloyd asked, “It’s about the new skill that you just got.”

“Bangul!”

“What does it do? Like, can you really make a volcano explode or something?”

“Bangul! Bba-bangul? Bangul!”

“Uhm, it’s similar but different?”

“Bangul!”

“Can you be more specific?”

“Bba-bangul! Bangul!”

“Hmm... Boom, and it explodes?”

“Bangul!” Bangul nodded her round head up and down.

Similar but different? It goes boom and explodes?

Her answers weren’t detailed enough for Lloyd to figure out what it specifically did.

I think the surest way for me to know what it does is to see it myself.

Lloyd tucked the three summon creatures back into his inner pocket. He put on his coat again and went out of the forge.

I need to go a bit further.

Lloyd decided to go somewhere with zero people, somewhere without any houses around.

He needed to get to a place where no damage would be done, even when the explosion went off.

I don’t know what the skill does yet.

It was best to exert utmost caution. He stopped by the inn and woke Javier up.

“Hey, wake up.”

“Uhm...”

“I said, wake up,” said Lloyd again.

“Hmm...” Javier didn’t budge.

“Open your eyes and get up, Lady Asrahan.”

“What in the world did you just say?”

“Gosh, look at you, snapping your eyes open at that.”

“I couldn’t help it when you mocked me like that,” Javier said, his voice husky.

“That means you were already awake before I mocked you,” pointed out Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“You were just pretending to be asleep because you didn’t want to wake up, weren’t you?”

“Yes.”

“Wow. You don’t even deny it now.”

“I wanted to sleep in as much as possible.”

Javier stretched his neck and sat up from his bed.

He rubbed his heavy eyelids, and it looked like he was forced to wake up from his deep sleep. The sight made Lloyd realize that he had just committed a mischievous act of waking an insomniac in the middle of the night. A regretful smile was formed on Lloyd’s face.

“Well, there’s nothing we can do. The situation calls for it.”

“Situation?”

“I need you to protect me for a second,” said Lloyd.

“Protect you? What do you mean?”

Javier, who was struggling to fight the assaulting grogginess, instantly woke up. Lloyd’s smile deepened.

“From a volcanic explosion.”

“Excuse me?”

“I need you to protect me from the volcanic explosion.”

“Hey?” Lloyd called.

“Why are you so quiet?”

“May I be honest with you?” asked Javier.

“Yeah.”

“I was silent because I was just figuring out a way to defend you against mental illness.”

“I need you to protect me from a volcano eruption, not mental illness.”

“I’m becoming even more desperately worried.”

“Excuse me? I’m telling you the truth right now,” insisted Lloyd.

Lloyd brought Bangul out. She flashed a big smile at Javier when she saw him.

“She’s going to create a volcanic explosion,” explained Lloyd.

“Excuse me...?”

“It’s true, isn’t it, Bangul?”

“Bangul!” Bangul excitedly nodded up and down.

Javier’s gaze sharpened.

“I knew it was true,” affirmed Javier.

“Hey, do you trust Bangul more than you trust me?” asked Lloyd in disbelief.

“That is because Bangul, Ppodong, and Hamang never lie. They are not like someone here who wickedly smiles after duping someone.”

“Tsk.”

It had been a while since Javier dropped a truth bomb. Lloyd thought that the knight truly had a wonderful talent for knocking someone out with his words. Yet, because of his serious and solemn attitude, it made things more difficult for Lloyd to parry that blow.

He’s a prodigy, indeed.

Suppressing a smile, Lloyd said, “Well, anyway, it looks like Bangul here has learned a new skill. She can erupt a volcano or do something of the kind.”

“And you are testing the new skill?”

“Yeah. I can’t gauge the power of her skill just yet.”

“I understand.”

Javier took the coat and sword, following Lloyd who walked out of the inn.

They walked through the dark alley, cutting across the city district. They headed towards the opposite way of the coast and entered the inland. Here, they passed the gate without being noticed by the guards and entered the unpopulated woods in the middle of the night.

Later, a large plain lot came into view.

This seems appropriate.

Lloyd put Bangul down at the center of the lot. He handed her the red sunflower seed.

“Hey, Bangul,” called Lloyd.

“Bangul?”

“Dear Bangul, would you like some midnight snacks?”

“Bba-bangul?!”

“Here you go. Sunflower seeds,” said Lloyd.

“Bangul!”

Bangul, who sniffed the smell of the sunflower seeds, wagged her short and fat tail. He put the sunflower seed in her mouth and quickly jumped back a few steps.

The transformation occurred in a flash.

Boom! Bangul, who was previously less than half a foot, turned into a 16-foot giant snake.

Lloyd called, “Bangul?”

“Bangul?”

“If you don’t mind, can you use the Volcanic Eruption skill later?”

“Bangul!”

“Yes, thank you. When I give you the signal, use it.”

“Bangul!”

“By the way, your skill,” said Lloyd.

“Bangul?”

“It’s not going to wipe out this forest or anything, is it?”

“Bangul! Bba-bangul! Bangul!”

“What? It depends on which direction you use it?”

“Bangul!”

“So does that mean you can set it in a particular direction?”

“Bangul!” Bangul’s gigantic head nodded in excitement.

She feigned to cover her ears with her fat tail.

“Bba-bangul. Bangul!”

“Oh, are you telling me to cover my ears so they don’t get hurt?”

“Bangul!”

“Does that mean I don’t have to stay far away?”

“Bangul!”

She nodded once again, and that was when it occurred to Lloyd that this blast skill seemed to be a bit different from a literal volcanic eruption.

Feeling a little relieved, Lloyd said, “Okay, so use the volcanic eruption skill when I send the signal. Got it?”

“Bangul!”

Bangul lifted her tail up as if she were raising a thumb. Lloyd distanced himself away from Bangul about thirty feet. He hid behind Javier, who drew his sword.

“I am ready,” said Javier.

Lloyd guessed that Javier planned on making a shield out of the sword aura by wielding the weapon at lightning speed. That was why he didn’t need any shields. Feeling confident and reassured, Lloyd shouted aloud at Bangul, “Okay, Bangul! Let’s begin!”

“Bangul!” responded Bangul, who was far away.

She then got to work, devouring the dirt on the ground. Her chubby body then trembled, seemingly digesting it, and she wagged her tail forcefully.

The bell attached to her tail rang aloud a clear warning.

She lifted her tail all the way up, and this process was nothing different from her usual skill of excreting metals. What came after was drastically different.

The area thundered as if a real volcano was erupting. At the same time, a fierce, violent phenomenon took place from her stomach and bottom.

Magma made from the earth she had just eaten, discharged out, and underwent a dramatic change as it touched the air.

Unlike the high pressure and temperature of her body, the world outside operated in a different setting.

The pressure was extremely low, and there was a difference in temperature by hundreds of degrees at least.

So, the magma that erupted out of her body saw a dramatic decrease in pressure and temperature, plummeting the body pressure of the magma.

The inflammable material melted inside, as the magma swirled. The water boiled and the carbon dioxide went berserk. The same thing happened with chlorine, fluorine, sulfuric substances, and carbon monoxide. All of the gasses vaporized at the same time, bursting out of the magma like an explosion.

A great implosion. The magma shredded to pieces at once to micrometers, spraying out in the air into millions and billions of volcanic ashes.

Even though it was a long process for the magma to turn into volcanic ash, the reaction actually took less than a second. The explosion was followed by a series of others.

A fart held for long didn’t stop after one time. The volcanic explosion occurred three consecutive times until it finally stopped.

“Wow.”

Lloyd unconsciously let out a sound of admiration.

Wow. This is nuts. It's nuts!

Lloyd tapped both of his ears with his palm as they had become numb even with the cover on. When Lloyd looked straight ahead, he realized that his deafening ears weren't the real problem.

The trees have fallen.

The trees that stood right in the course of the volcanic explosion were pummeled to the ground like a domino.

He roughly counted it to be over fifty. He didn't run toward it right away. He had something else to check first before seeing the result of the volcanic eruption.

"Hey, you okay?"

"Hey?"

Javier didn't answer. So Lloyd tapped his shoulders. That was when Javier flinched his body and turned his body to Lloyd's side.

Javier then said, "Did you call me?"

"Yeah. Hey, can't you hear anything?"

"I cannot hear what you are saying well."

"Oh... I'm sorry. I forgot to tell you that you should cover up your ears."

"Excuse me?"

"Nothing. It's going to be all right soon."

"Excuse me?"

"Should I get you some hearing aids?"

“Excuse me?”

“Never mind... Just wait here.”

The dude has super sensitive hearing senses because of the sword master symptoms. The blaring must have hit him hard when he took that in without any protection.

Lloyd motioned to wait here and walked over to Bangul.

“Bangul. Are you alright?”

“Bangul!”

“What? You feel completely refreshed?”

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

“Uhm, I don’t think we can do that again now. How about we do it next time?”

“Bangul!”

He then headed to the explosion site, leaving Bangul in her wistfulness. The place had turned into an ashen world. The ashes still rained down from the sky like snow, carpeting the whole ground in gray.

The patches of grass, flowers, and trees all turned gray, looking much like...

It’s like the whole place is covered with volcanic dust.

Lloyd’s eyes stung. So he covered his mouth and nose with his sleeve. He then narrowed his eyes as much as possible and observed the ground, activating the surveying skill.

Once the skill was activated, various information on the surface floated in front of him.

He saw the clear slope of the ground, as well as the bedrock and soil.

At last, he saw the layer of gray ash on top of them.

My, it really is the ash from the volcanoes!

Lloyd's narrowed eyes widened in surprise. He instinctively bent over, stretched out his hands, and touched the gray ash covering the ground.

It felt soft, much smoother than the flour.

It's real.

It was the volcanic ash he had wanted to get his hands on for so long. It was the key ingredient that would instantly solve the cement issue. Now, that very material was sitting in front of him by the handful. Plus, he could make more at any time as he wished! His heart began to beat violently.

Jackpot. Wow, this is awesome. First, she gives me metal bars, and now, she's making volcanic ash that will become the major ingredient of cement.

Lloyd sweetly gazed at Bangul as if he were looking at a gold-laying goose.

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After that, their work progressed smoothly. It was all thanks to Bangul's new skill that was acquired after upgrading her. The following day, Lloyd headed to the shipbuilding yard at the dock. He purchased five huge sheets of masts and had people tightly knead them together.

The final output looked like a large cylindrical diaper. At one end of the diaper, Lloyd attached five dense sheets of sifter that would filter out tiny particles from the air. On the opposite end, he made a hole that was about thirty feet in diameter. Bangul put her waist into the hole. She was now wearing a balloon-shaped diaper that was about ninety-eight feet long. Then, she ate the earth in the center plaza of Cremo city, shaking her body as she digested it.

The bell affixed to her tail rang.

It signaled the implosion. Lloyd instantly cupped his hands over his mouth when he heard the ringing and shouted at the top of his lungs toward the people in the plaza, “Cover up your ears! It’s going to blast!”

Bangul’s volcanic skill happened right inside the diaper. The extreme heat of the ash and gas caused the diaper to inflate, and they were filtered through the five sheets of sifters attached to the other end.

The gas slowly traveled out of the diaper, leaving only the ash in.

And Lloyd shouted once more. “Another one incoming!”

The skill created a series of explosions one after another.

The people in the city exclaimed at the rare sight each time. The passing merchants and ship crew members widened their eyes at such an exotic sight. Later, even the guards of the city and Count Cremo himself came out to observe the scene.

“Is this why you asked for permission to blast something in the middle of the city?” asked Count Cremo.

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“Hmm, I didn’t know you could tame summon creatures.”

“I was just lucky,” said Lloyd.

“Lucky? No, summoning is not as easy as you say it is.”

Count Cremo was right. Taming a summoned creature required magical talent and rapport with the creature.

Plus, I heard the rarer the creature gets, the harder it becomes for the owner to control them.

Even though the count was an erudite man, he had never seen anything like Bangul before. He was amazed at how this giant rattlesnake could chomp

the dirt and blast volcanic ash. She was something he had never heard or even imagined before.

This friend is not an ordinary fellow. Likewise, for the young knight he takes along with him.

Suddenly, the rumor he had heard recently interrupted his thoughts. The rumor was about how two skillful young men from the eastern mountain range began to make their names.

I vaguely remember that it was about the eldest son of the baron who consolidated the whole barony using his mysterious construction skills and the knight who was already at the level of a high-level sword expert at twenty.

The baron intently gazed at Lloyd and Javier. His gaze wasn't laden with envy or avarice. It was more filled with satisfaction.

I need to watch over how this project goes.

He would be taking a keen eye on those two and find out if the rumors were true.

Once he saw the boldness and tact in their works as the rumors said they were, he decided that he would report to the king in detail.

It would only be a loss for the nation if two talented individuals were made to rot in a rural province. They had to find a bigger playing field where they could fulfill their wildest dreams. The kingdom would become stronger as a result. The mere thought of it overwhelmed his heart. The count thought to himself that he had just discovered today their very talents.

A sense of satisfaction swept over him. Each time his smile deepened in contentment, the louder Lloyd's shout rang aloud throughout the plaza. Each time Lloyd's voice rang louder, the stacks of the volcanic ash grew higher. Lloyd's construction of artificial ground in the sea was a stage that would introduce his name to the whole world. Now, that stage was starting to take shape in full force.

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Chapter 67: The Luxurious Completion Ceremony (1)

“Watch out! Take it slowly now!”

The biting winter wind blew through the coast of the Cremo pier.

The wind brought the winds to be washed toward the port. They were blocked by the flank of a sailboat, whose large body tittered up and down in the water as a result.

The crane, which sat on the deck of the sailboat, naturally trembled along. Lloyd’s gaze turned sharper each time the boat was hit with another wave. Leaning over the ledge of the sailboat, he laser-focused as he stared at the sea underneath. The captain walked over to Lloyd.

“Did it move to the side?”

“Yes, it moved about twenty inches to the left.”

“Twenty inches? Do I have to realign the distance again?”

“Of course.”

Lloyd lifted his head and turned around to face the captain.

“We cannot allow a single inch of error here, especially when you think about the size and shape of the Caisson hanging in the air by the crane right now.” Lloyd spoke and pointed above.

The captain’s gaze followed his fingers, and at last, the captain was able to spot the two cranes installed on each deck of two sailboats.

There was a huge structure lifted in the air by the two juxtaposed cranes. The structure was called ‘Caisson’ according to Lloyd. It was fifty-two feet in length and width.

With its ninety-eight foot height, it was a huge box made out of thick wood.

The top and bottom were empty and open. The antique and huge wooden box that was nothing but frames was being transported in the air as it dangled along in between the two sailboats. The captain thought to himself, *What is the use of it?*

According to the one in charge, Lloyd, it wasn't to have it afloat. It was to be sunk down.

Then, what's the point of transporting the box and having it sink to the ground?

The captain could not wrap his head around this project. The corners of Lloyd's lips rose.

"I am sure you can't guess it. That Caisson was designed and produced to fit the area where it should be placed on. What do you think will happen if the box is placed at the wrong location?"

"Uhm, maybe..."

"The whole construction will be ruined, don't you think?"

"And Count Cremo would be filled with an emotion that is far from happiness, yes?"

"He will kindly invite you over and hold you accountable."

"Do you think you would have the guts to be held responsible for that situation?" asked Lloyd.

"Of course not."

"I thought so, too."

"Them, uhm, I just have to move twenty inches to the right?"

"Yes. That's perfect. Thank you."

"No problem."

Lloyd grinned. The captain then jumped to his feet and started urging his crew, and everyone began to run about doing their work.

The two sailboats shifted to the right. Now, with a gaze that grew sharper than before, Lloyd observed the sea. He activated the survey and design skill at the same time.

He observed the subterranean land with his survey skill to find out how it would turn out.

The optional skill of survey was then activated.

[Skill Option 2: Floor Plan Marking (3D) has been activated.]

A hologram footage overlapped in front of his eyes. The artificial ground Lloyd had mapped out by using the design skill and simulation skill was shown in a three-dimensional floor plan under the water.

Thanks to it, the accurate location of the Caisson was identified.

Lloyd held up his thumb at the captain. The captain yelled something, and the rope in the crane loosened to bring down the large Caisson into the water.

The water splashed as the box became submerged.

The box kept going down until it finally touched the bottom.

Not a single inch was missed. It landed exactly where Lloyd had designed it to.

We’re off to a good start.

Lloyd felt relieved now that the location of the Caisson was perfect. Two days later Lloyd had ordered hundreds of wood piles.

“It needs to be fifty feet long, and one foot in diameter. The wood must be a poplar tree, and please remove the skin and prune them up,” instructed Lloyd.

“Poplar tree?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded his head at the butler’s question.

“Because it’s the easiest to find and is resistant against humidity.”

It was true. Poplar trees had been used in building the foundation in the city of Venice. In particular, it was used in building the St. Mark Basilica, the landmark in Venice. The poplar tree was historically known for its durability.

“So please get the most sturdy ones. It would be best if you could get them as early as possible.”

“Huh? Haha, I see.”

Lloyd hurried the butler, following the Korean way of working quickly and fast. The butler was taken aback at the fast pace. Anyway, thanks to his urgency, Lloyd was able to receive the wood only three days later. Around the time, the Caisson was already settled well into the bottom of the sea. It was all because of the weight of the box.

Plus, the seabed is flat and muddy.

Thankfully, the bed of the sea was extremely soft. Once the heavy object was placed on the soft floor, the sheer weight of the structure pressed deep into the mud.

It was the same principle with the car in the swamp or sandy beach getting its wheels stuck because of the weight. Just like that, the large box Caisson dug into the soft layer, penetrating as far as the Caranto layer where the clay and sand were mixed.

This was the reason the box was designed to have an open bottom. On the other hand, the reason for the open top was to drain water.

“Alright, Hamang,” said Lloyd.

“Hamang!”

“How do you like salty water?”

“Hamang! Hamamang!”

“You like it because it’s salty, eh?”

“Hamang!”

“Great. There’s tons of salty water here just for you.”

“Hamang!”

“Do you see the water in the Caisson over here?”

“Hamamang!”

“Yes, you can drink it all.”

“Hamang!”

Hamang jumped into the Caisson which looked much like a swimming pool.

He opened his mouth wide and began chugging the sea.

A whirlpool appeared around him.

Hamang’s body bloated like a water balloon. The water level inside the Caisson dropped immediately. It dropped from 150 feet to one hundred and to fifty... until the bottom appeared.

“Hamamang! Hamang!”

Lloyd had prepared a bamboo straw for Hamang who had gotten gigantic in size. Thanks to the straw, Hamang was able to drink every single drop of the seawater in the box without anything left.

“Hamaang!”

As Hamang happily smiled, the inside of the Caisson turned soft and all dried up. Now, the bottom of the sea, where the artificial ground will be constructed, was completely revealed. The water could not enter from the outside because of the upper block of Caisson that prevented the wave from splashing into the box.

As for the bottom, the penetration of hundreds of feet deep into the Caranto layer made it impossible for the seawater to enter. In other words, a dry construction site was made available right in the middle of the sea.

I succeeded. It’s a relief that it ended well.

Lloyd clenched his fists. The Box Caisson method was a modern thing, and it worked quite perfectly for this situation.

There was a time once when nervousness flooded into his heart. He feared that the new technique might fail, that the water might come into the box.

So he ran countless simulations and touched up the design to perfect it. As the result of painstaking efforts and research...

No water is coming in. The box is completely sealed. It’s perfect.

The first stage of the construction was a success. Up next, he moved on to the next part of the construction, the insertion of friction piles.

“Alright, Javier.”

“Your turn has come at last.”

“Excited, yeah? I bet your heart is racing,” said Lloyd.

“Not really, whew...”

Javier sighed at length. He gazed at the wooden mallet he was holding up. He wasn’t sure if he could call it a mallet.

It looks more like a battering ram.

Javier was right indeed. The hammer was ginormous. Its head was more than thirty feet long. Its handle, which was as thick as an arm, was made of steel. The overall length reached over sixty feet. No matter how many times he looked at it, he came to a conclusion that this wasn't for human use. So, he started to develop feelings of dislike for Lloyd who had handed him such a mallet in his hands.

"Could it be that Young Master Lloyd is..."

Javier's voice became sharpened when he turned around to face Lloyd.

"Do you consider me as nothing but a construction tool?"

"Mhm, of course," replied Lloyd matter-of-factly.

"I have been thinking so, and I always will be."

"But I am a knight," defied Javier.

"Yes, I know."

"I did not learn sword fighting to do this kind of work every day."

"Then you better change your mind from now on."

"By that, you mean..."

"Change your mind to think that you've learned how to use the sword for this kind of work. All right?"

"Wow, so rewarding, don't you think?"

"What in the…"

"Hey, the world depends on how you look at it. Have you ever heard of Monk Wonhyo?"

“No, I have not. And I do not wish to change my mind that way,” retorted Javier.

“My, my. How pessimistic you view the world, young man.”

“Please correct the word in your sentence. It’s not the world but you Master Lloyd that I am perceiving with pessimism.”

“And yet, you are holding up the hammer so obediently.”

“Well, that’s...”

“I presume it’s in your best interest to not lose the lullaby service.”

“Anyway, enough with the grumbling. Shall we get to work?”

Lloyd picked up and straightened the huge pile, placing it down and holding it still.

A normal person would have strained so badly just to hold it.

Lloyd managed to endure through his use of the Asrahan Core Technique.

Lloyd, with his face all sweaty and wet, grinned.

“Do it in one try. Precisely. Okay?”

“Yes...”

Javier reluctantly fixed his grip on the hammer. He looked up at the wooden friction file. Soon after, the silver-haired knight leaped in the air.

He jumped in a flash.

He raised the hammer that was similar to a battering ram. As his blue eyes glimmered, he brought his hammer down hard.

The hammer hit right on the spot.

Javier, the high-level sword expert. He had utilized all the mana in his manaheart and the mana that had been amplified by the triple circle. The result was marvelous.

The fifty-foot pile drove right into the roots.

The corners of Lloyd's lips stretched up high.

"There. I knew you'd do a good job."

"Alright, one more."

Lloyd held the second pile vertically. With another sigh, Javier lifted the hammer. This process was repeated several times. The fifty-foot-long poplar tree pile was driven into the ground two feet in intervals.

Great. The pile is getting driven into properly.

Each time it dug right inside, the corners of Lloyd's lips rose further up in contentment. The wood pile was being dug into the ground of the sea. Lloyd was absolutely not worried that the pile would rot. He knew that there was zero chance for the woods to be in contact with the air as they were driven deep down.

Even logs of wood won't rot in the water as long as they are tightly dug into the earth. As long as they are not exposed to air, they will hold for at least a couple of centuries.

There were countless buildings in Venice still holding up to this day.

Javier jumped.

He then brought down the hammer that resembled a battering ram. Each time he did so, each pile dug deep into the ground.

"Good! Continue!"

"You do not have to hurry." Lloyd encouraged excitedly, while Javier gave a cold retort.

As the two made the exchange, another pile was stuck in the seabed. The statue Count Cremo wanted to put up held his hopes of reviving the dying port. The piles became firm ground for the statue to stand on.

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A few days passed. By now, over 700 piles had been driven into the seabed. The construction took a relentless pace without a pause. The upper sides of the piles were leveled, and afterward, they were looped with metal.

The workers then gradually added more rebars. They poured the cement into the Caisson. The cement was Roman-style, which was made possible by mixing the volcanic ash gathered thanks to Bangul.

Then came the deposit and cure process. The weather was perfect just in time. There was enough sunlight in the early winter. The wind was sufficiently dry. The deposited cement dried up decently, and after that, the workers removed the outlines of the Caisson.

They cut it up according to the height of the solidified cement ground. Once it was gone, the artificial ground that was fifteen feet by width and length and with a landmass of 2755 square feet was made.

“By the way, the height of the artificial ground was decided by design.”

“By design? What do you mean?” asked the count.

“Do you happen to know what time it is, Count Cremo?”

“Yes, I know it very well. It’s time for the high tide.”

“Yes, it is. I have set the elevation of the ground to be exactly 1.6 feet higher than the water level at high tide.”

“Haha, did you? I see.”

Lloyd confidently explained, and the count nodded as he heard it. The day had enough waves. Its head almost touched the top of the artificial ground but didn’t.

“This is excellent enough. If the Gigatitan sees from afar the mermaid statue that will be put up, it will certainly think the statue is floating on the water.”

“That is exactly what I aimed for.”

It was true. Moreover, the high and low tides here didn’t have a large difference in water level. This meant that even if the surface level lowered during the low tide, the artificial ground would be unrecognizable from afar as long as there were just enough waves.

“Great. Very good. But you do know that there is more work to be done, yes?” asked the count.

“Of course, Your Excellency.”

Lloyd caught on to what the count meant in a snap. His job was technically finished as the artificial ground had been successfully put up.

But the job wasn’t over yet.

The statue hasn’t been put up yet.

After all, the artificial ground he had created was nothing but a ground to erect the statue.

“I suppose it is my turn to wait,” said Lloyd.

“It won’t take long.”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

The time had come for the artists to come forward and make the statue. Lloyd would get paid only after the statue was completed. He had foreseen this already, so no explanation was needed.

It’s obviously understandable from the count’s shoes. He’s going to find himself in serious trouble if he pays me in advance only to find that the foundation of the statue is crumbling.

In other words, Lloyd needed to stay in the city for a while to make sure that he would be there when there was any need for repairs.

I should take this chance to rest for a few days. It had taken fifteen days for Lloyd to arrive at Cremo from his fiefdom.

He dove right into the construction preparation and got to work, putting his nose to the grindstone.

Therefore, rest was imperative. So throughout the period the statue was being put up, he rested very well.

He stayed in bed all day in the inn. Sometimes, he played word and riddle games with Javier. Javier received seven more letters from Lady Christine meanwhile. Each time Javier got one more, Lloyd shouted in frustration, “This is unfair!”

And finally, fifteen days later...The gigantic mermaid statue was completed. That night, the whole city held a grand completion ceremony. The count had six sailboats docked under the foot of the statue standing on the shore. It was a boat party. Of course, Lloyd and Javier were invited too. They dressed the part by putting on the tuxedos they had purchased downtown.

Well, what do you know, this statue looks just like the Statue of Liberty.

From where he was standing, the statue exuded its magnificence and beauty, and the sight made him proud and happy that he had designed and built the foundation of such a structure.

But there was something Lloyd was oblivious to. No, it was the same for everyone in the party and every worker calling it a day at the port. Not a single person could even imagine what was to come.

No one fathomed that a 295-foot-long, five-million-ton gigantic monster was studying the structure with monstrous ferocity in the distant sea.

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Chapter 68: The Luxurious Completion Ceremony (2)

The Gigatitan remained distant from the Cremo port. A huge tidal wave rushed and hit the monster’s eyes, which were as large as a rock.

The Gigatitan didn’t even blink. No, this ginormous monster didn’t have any eyelids to blink in the first place.

The Gigatitan’s eyes held a ferocious glare amid the splashing waves.

Its protruded eyes resembled that of a lobster or crab. Its two eyes used a total of sixteen colors, from the infrared light spectrum to the UV spectrum. They observed the sea near the port of Cremo with an eyesight dozens of times better than a human’s. As they watched, something that distressed its spirit came into view.

Its appendicular trembled violently.

It definitely saw a mermaid. The figure standing straight in the sea near the Cremo port was definitely a mermaid. It was a giant one it had never seen before.

The Gigatitan began to ponder.

The mermaids always made even this giant monster pause. Each one of them was powerful. Dozens and hundreds of soldiers teamed together to wage a large-scale hunt.

It wondered if it should swim away. After a few seconds, it shook its giant head. There was nowhere to run. There was only the deep sea waiting for it outside this offshore area. Something as uncomfortable and powerful as mermaids inhabited the place, its fellow kind.

The Gigatitan shook its tail in distaste when it recalled its fellow beings. A shameful memory assaulted his thoughts. There had been a war among its kind. It had to fend off its territory from the younger and stronger generations.

The humiliation of losing its territory.

So it couldn’t turn around and go back to where it came from. It’d only be shoved away by the younger and powerful ones.

If it is unlucky, one of them might smash its head and eat it up. So sticking to this place was imperative. For ten years, this part of the sea had served as a comfortable habitat for the aged and weakened monster. It was the ideal place of residence save for the downside that it could not meet its mate. Besides that, it was perfect as mermaids barely approached around here because it was near the large port run by humans.

There was no retreat. It couldn’t give up its habitat. Its large rock-like eyes flashed with incredible determination. Looking around the areas of the mermaid statue that stood offshore from the port, it was struck with a happy realization.

There were no other mermaids around. Only one strangely large mermaid stood in the area. Several things became clear in its head. One, it stood a chance against this mermaid left all alone herself. Second, it had to take care of that mermaid before she brought her own kind down here. Therefore, the Gigatitan decided to fight.

Its careful gaze started to grow ferocious. Two of its curled forearms began to tense up, simultaneously plunging its gigantic body into the water.

It hid underneath the violently splashing waves and began to charge forth assisted by the bottom of the sea.

It was bent on protecting its territory. It headed toward the waters near the port, where the giant mermaid statue stood.

The hundreds of people enjoying the party on board had zero clue what was coming.

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“Hmm?”

Javier paused, but he didn’t know why. The fruit drink in his cup trembled when he was about to drink it. Several drops of the drink splashed out of the cup to ruin his scarf. Javier didn’t give a hoot about the smudges. His eyes simply focused straight ahead. He narrowed his eyes to slits with a frown on his face.

“What are you doing? Are you going to the bathroom?” said Lloyd, shattering Javier’s focus.

When Javier heard Lloyd’s question, he was provoked for a split second. He mustered up enough patience to reply, “I do not think the bathroom is the problem.”

“Then what is the problem? You’re frowning like you are upset.”

“Something is wrong.”

“Something is wrong?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“What is?”

“Look over there.”

Javier lifted his hand and pointed at the far distance in the sea. Lloyd looked at it and shrugged.

“I do not see anything except for the beautiful night sea that dances under the dusk.”

“I agree. There is nothing visible there. But something is...”

“What is it?”

“Something just feels wrong.”

Lloyd tilted his head to the side a little.

When he stared at Javier’s face, he could feel it right away. Javier wasn’t joking. He meant it when he said that something was off.

Javier is like that. He’s always serious and prudent.

Lloyd’s face and gaze turned serious as well.

“Be more specific.”

“Something seems to be moving...underwater.”

“Right down here?”

“No, far in the distance.”

“Could it be a whale or something?” asked Lloyd.

“It is way larger. And...it seems to be heading toward this direction.”

“What?”

No way.

Lloyd asked, “Can you sense how big it is?”

“Yes, but just an estimate. By length, it seems to be larger than Hamang when he turns gigantic.”

“Are you sure about this?”

“Yes, I am,” said Javier as he looked straight into Lloyd’s eyes.

Javier’s that serious. It’s gotta be true.

Lloyd trusted him wholeheartedly.

Javier will soon become a sword master. He’s experiencing sword master syndrome, which heightens his senses to an unnecessarily max level.

So it was possible for Javier to sense the incoming creature from dozens of miles away. That was even more true for Javier if the creature was larger.

I have a bad feeling about this.

Lloyd gulped dryly, an ominous image taking over him.

He could only think of one entity that was larger than Hamang in these waters.

The Gigatitan. What else?

The monster was swimming near? Lloyd looked around, and he saw dozens of people enjoying the party on deck luxuriously decorated with ornaments.

An orchestra was playing soothing music in one corner, and everyone was donned with expensive clothes as they chatted with one another. Some sipped their drinks with elegant smiles on their faces. Some adored the magnificence of the mermaid statue. There were also some couples dancing slowly to the music. Lloyd's gaze scanned around the groups of people fast, and he finally spotted his target among them.

His target was no other than Count Cremo, the host of the party and owner of this city.

"Hey," said Lloyd, "you didn't drink, did you?"

"Of course not."

"Okay, that clears out the possibility that you're drunkenly talking. Alright, wait for my instructions."

Lloyd then walked away after giving an order to Javier. Lloyd passed through the crowd and got near the count.

"Well, well, well. Look who we have here. The man who built the foundation of our joy today. Welcome, welcome." Count Cremo broke into a guffaw when he saw Lloyd.

He motioned to the people around him and said, “I got too carried away by the joyous occasion that I forgot to introduce this man to you all. He is Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera barony. He is also the one who built the sturdy foundation that sits beneath the statue.”

Count grabbed Lloyd’s shoulder and introduced him to everyone. The old men and women, who seemed to exert considerable influence in the city, began to focus on Lloyd. But none of it mattered to Lloyd at the moment.

He pretended to cough. “Ehem. Hmm! Your Excellency. May I have a word with you?” asked Lloyd.

“What?” The count’s eyebrow twitched, his gaze wanting to know what it was about.

Lloyd’s voice grew more serious, sounding heavier. “It appears that the Gigatitan is heading this way.”

“What is that?”

This time, both of his eyebrows lifted upward.

“Gigatitan is coming near?”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“Are you certain?”

“The least we can do is to check it right now.”

Lloyd continued to explain. “My personal knight felt something suspicious. He said that something gigantic is coming towards us underwater.”

“You think it is the monster?” asked the count.

“Based on the size he can feel, yes, it is.”

“Hmm.”

The count’s head cocked to the side. His gaze looked doubtful.

“By any chance you are drunk?”

“No. I have not had a sip.”

“That makes it even stranger. Your personal knight and his senses. Can he ascertain it to be true?”

The count’s gaze traveled to the side. A sharp-looking middle-aged man was standing there.

“This is Sir Genovan. He is my personal knight and a talented man who is almost at the level of a high-rank sword expert. In other words, he, too, is suffering from the sword master syndrome.” Directing to Sir Genovan, he said, “Sir Genovan, do you feel anything strange in the distant sea?”

“Nothing, Your Excellency,” replied Sir Genovan with confidence.

Count Cremo’s gaze returned to Lloyd.

“Did you see? According to Sir Genovan’s senses, nothing is wrong. Moreover, if the Gigatitan was truly drawing near, countless coastal guard posts should have already set off the alarm. Are you, by any chance, distrusting the alarm system in my city which lived with the monster for the last ten years?” The count looked intently at him.

“No, that’s not it, Your Excellency.” Lloyd shook his head immediately.

Then, he plastered a salesman-like smile on his face.

“It appears that my personal knight and I have acted out of line because this is the first time we have attended such a fancy event like this.”

“Haha, it is all right. I can understand. Anyway, it does not change the fact that you have helped the city in a great way.”

“I am honored to hear that, Your Excellency,” replied Lloyd.

“Well, well, showing such humility. What a man of great character. Everyone, did you see that?”

The count turned around and faced the powerful men and women in the audience. They all replied to him with satisfied smiles. The count tapped Lloyd’s shoulder with his thick and large palm.

“It must have been considered difficult,” said Count Cremo, “to give such a warning under this kind of environment, but he worked up the courage to do so. It shows how much care he has for this city. Haha. I have never imagined meeting such a young man in a remote province. What a blissful day it is today. Everyone, raise your glasses. Now, raise it too, young man.” He paused and looked at Lloyd and then continued, “Today, take pride in your work and enjoy it. I shall make sure that you will be paid generously, so do not worry about anything.”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

Lloyd couldn’t help but smile in dismay.

Crap. This is bad.

Lloyd took the glass from the count and lifted it up to cheer with everyone, stealing a quick glance to the side.

Javier was looking at Lloyd. He nodded slightly. Lloyd understood right away. Javier was certain about what he felt. Lloyd bit his underlip without the count’s knowledge.

I can’t insist that the monster is coming when the count has made such a loud and clear announcement. I’m going to make a bad impression on the man. What should I do?

Lloyd trusted Javier more than the count’s big talk. He did so even when the count’s personal knight Sir Genovan said he didn’t feel anything.

Javier’s senses would be more precise.

Lloyd recalled the story in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* He couldn't remember reading anything about Sir Genovan. It only meant one thing, then. Sir Genovan was a nobody until the end of the novel. In other words, the knight wasn't good enough to become a sword master. Even if Javier and Genovan were both the same high-level sword experts, the latter would seriously fall behind in fighting.

So it goes without saying that Javier's senses are more precise.

"Cheers!"

Lloyd heard the count shout aloud. He put the glass to his mouth and pretended to drink it. After excusing himself, he quickly removed himself from the group. The plan to warn the count and respond to the danger failed. So now, it was time for Lloyd to take the matter into his own hands.

What should I do...Oh, that's it.

Lloyd was looking around when he stopped at the sides of the boat. There were thick ropes that tied the sides. The ropes were tied to the metal stakes installed at the foot of the statue. They were holding down the boats from drifting off by the waves and tides, making sure that they remained at their own places. Lloyd scanned his surroundings. No one was looking at him.

The musicians were engrossed in their performance. The waiters were busy serving drinks and food. The nobles and merchants were enjoying the party. Not a single person paid attention to Lloyd. The same thing was happening on the decks of the other boats where the party was going in full swing.

It's a do-or-die situation.

Lloyd quickly moved to Javier, and they exchanged glances.

Lloyd held out his hand and grabbed the hilt of the sword Javier tucked around his waist. He pulled it out.

The long sword glinted sharply against the light of the fading sun.

Lloyd quickened his steps.

In one stroke.

Not a moment was spared for the others to respond. It happened so fast that no one knew Lloyd had drawn a sword. Lloyd jumped over the side and landed on the cement ground of the statue. Then he struck down the ropes tied to the stakes.

The six ropes, which were as thick as arms, began to cut one by one. When the boats lost the ropes that kept them fixed and rooted, they began to stagger by the waves. People enjoying the party reeled just then, and the music came to a halt. Wine glasses dropped to the ground, shattering.

Amid the such ruckus, however, Lloyd didn't stop. He jumped back to the boat. He passed the side and sprinted toward the stern, where there was a capstan that pulled up the anchor. Lloyd lifted his sword high once again.

The rope connected to the device got torn. He had cut off the rope that was connected to the anchor, the ropes and anchor for docking, and the front and rear of the boat. The ropes that tied the boat from the front and back were now gone. This got the large boat to stagger and move at full force. It didn't take long until the waves and tides started drifting them off the statue. The whole deck went berserk as a result.

"Eh? Eh? What's going on?"

"The boat is moving!"

"Ahhh!! That man! He's holding a sword!" A lady shrilled and pointed at Lloyd among the crowds. Her shrill pitch was raised when she saw the long sword in his hands.

Lloyd didn't care. He instead got on the ledge of the boat and yelled at the five others still lingering around the statue.

"If you want to live more, then cut off the ropes right now and disperse as much as possible!"

Just when Lloyd shouted and just when the count was about to bawl at Lloyd and ask what in the world he was doing...

At that moment...

A ginormous silhouette shot out from underneath. It crashed down on the five boats left around the statue, creating explosive waves as a result.

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Chapter 69: A Runaway and a Fighter (1)

An explosive spray burst up beneath the water. A gigantic silhouette rushed out in between. It was the sea monster, who was 295 feet tall and weighed about 2,500 tons.

The Gigatitan roared as it straightened its curled body. Breaking the splashing waves in one stroke, the Gigatitan hurtled forth like a giant meteor, striking the waist of the mermaid statue with its leviathan head.

Its head was dense with dentin and chitin, and its body weighed 2,500 tons kilograms. As such, the statue couldn’t hold out against the weighty blow. The statue was huge, sure, but its height was a mere ninety-five feet. It was nothing but a toy compared to the gigantic size of the sea monster. So, the blow snapped the statue in the waist like a twig.

Half of its upper torso was sent flying away like a rock shooting out from a catapult.

It cut across the sky of the Cremo pier and flew almost a mile. It crashed right in the middle of the plaza of Cremo city that basked in the tranquility of the night.

The abrupt descent of the statue sent several tons of rocks falling from the sky. The pavement and fountain were instantly destroyed, and the statue bounced and rolled toward the edge of the plaza.

As a result, five peaceful buildings, including the bakery, flower shop, and fruit store, were crumbled to dust. However, it continued to roll on and cut across a major road to finally get stuck in a bell tower. Screams followed right after.

“Arghhhhh!!”

“Eeeek!”

“What?! What is that?!!”

“Over here! Right over here! Someone passed out!”

“Somebody help us!”

The statue dropped like a dead fly and smashed nearby buildings. People became stuck under the debris, and their screams for help were mixed with the shouts of their rescuers.

Some terrified people ran for their lives amid the thick clouds of dust and debris. It was chaos. The terrors of the night could not come any more unexpected. Such horrors were clearly visible from the offshore sailboat.

“What...What is this...?! Christine! Hold my hand, and don’t let go!”

The middle-aged man, Count Cremo, was tightly holding his daughter’s hand as the great disaster swept over the city. His eyes widened in horror. A shocking noise spilled out of his gaping mouth. He couldn’t believe what was unfolding at the moment. The disaster before his very eyes felt unreal. It was beyond his imagination and shattered his grip on reality.

Why? Why did that monster come all the way here and attack?

He couldn’t understand it, and it was for a good reason. The Gigatitan appeared only at the front of the sea for the last ten years. When it did, it just attacked the ships navigating around the area. It had never come so close to attacking the city before.

Could it be...because of the mermaid statue?

The count’s frowning eyes traveled to the statue. The statue that stood with overflowing dignity was now gone. The only remaining portion of the structure was below its waist, and even that was still smashed to pieces. The count’s brow furrowed all the more.

I had wished that the Gigatitan would move its habitat after being intimidated by the statue.

The situation appeared to have taken a different turn. Instead of moving somewhere else, it seemed to have decided to attack the mermaid statue that

was judged to be a threat.

This realization grieved the count’s heart.

It is my fault.

His gaze fell heavily. Things started to piece together in his head.

This is because of the mermaid statue. That’s why the Gigatitan acted differently and the coastal posts failed to discover its emergence earlier.

The monster wasn’t acting as it usually did. Each time it had revealed itself in the past, it roared from the distant sea. Thus, its imposing roar allowed the guards to detect the monster’s emergence easily. For the past ten years, the monster emerged in this pattern: it warned and roared whenever the ships crossed its turf.

The guards only had to raise the alarm after detecting its presence above the sea.

However, today was different.

The monster approached underwater. It was shockingly discreet yet determined.

This time, it didn’t act to simply reaffirm its territory and show off its power. It didn’t parade. It attacked. It wasn't a threat. It retaliated against the intruder. That was a new behavioral pattern the monster manifested today.

And the only ones that saw it coming were them.

The count’s gaze moved to the other side of the deck. Two young men were standing there, Lloyd and Javier.

The personal knight of the confident fellow over there. Did he sense the approaching Gigatitan under the water?

His own knight, Sir Genovan, had missed it, but that silver-haired knight felt it. What it meant was evident.

“It’s dangerous, my lord! Do not let go of my hand!”

A strong grip was stretched out toward the count, who was deep in thought. The grip then grabbed his wrist hard and gave a tug as if it were trying to save a drowning man. The grip forcefully pulled him in. Thanks to it, however, the count and his daughter were able to stand strong on the tumultuous deck without tumbling to the ground.

“Please forgive me, my lord.”

The voice trembled as it yelled. It was Sir Genovan, the personal knight of the count.

He was gazing at the count with dolorous eyes. A regretful smile faintly formed on the count’s face.

“Do not beat on yourself,” comforted the count.

“But my lord, I…”

“You have tried your best. It is simply that your best was not able to be as good as the silver-haired knight over there. No one in the city felt the Gigatitan approaching. I, too, missed it. So the fault does not lie upon a single man,” said the count.

“Lord...”

“You have done nothing wrong in this situation. If there is someone who’s at fault, it is me.” The count’s voice grew more distressed.

Just then, a sharp, pointy scream pierced his ears.

“Your Excellency! I am sure it’s nice building trust with your faithful knight, but could you please hear me out for a second?”

It was Lloyd. Grabbing onto the ledge on the other side of the deck, Lloyd spoke aloud.

“People have fallen into the water! Please call the captain at once!”

Lloyd was pointing at the sea, and there, the count saw the mess in the area. Five sailboats that failed to move away from the statue were smashed to pieces. The majority of those on board were now in the water. Making things worse, the waves crashed up and down violently. It was all because of the Gigatitan. Currently, the 295-foot body of the monster was violently tumbling in the water, and the area near the violent ripples was pure chaos. It had created a swirl of flailing people and boat debris in the sea. Lloyd continued to shout.

“We must save them first! Quick! Please commandeer this boat and save as many people as you can! I shall head to the city!”

“City? What are you talking about?!” yelled the count.

“It looks like the port is going to meet a large unwelcome guest!”

Once again, Lloyd pointed somewhere. He was pointing at the Gigatitan whose head was now shot up. It was staring intently at a fixed point as its body stood amid the rippling waves. At the end of its gaze was no other than the mermaid statue. A few hundred feet away, the upper torso of the mermaid statue was laterally stuck in the spire.

“It looks like that monster thinks the mermaid is still alive!”

“Wait a minute, do you think it will rush into the city to break the rest of it?” screamed the count.

“I wouldn’t be surprised if it does!”

Some moments after Lloyd’s answer rang aloud, the Gigatitan began to move as if to prove that he was right. After lowering its body, the monster moved forward, dividing the waves and swimming toward the city.

“Once it gets to the city, the damage will be unimaginable!”

“Then, what do you suggest we do?!” shouted the count.

“I will go!”

“What?”

The count doubted what he had just heard.

Go there? What does he mean? Is he going to swim over to the place?

Lloyd didn’t explain anything more. As though he couldn’t waste his time elaborating, Lloyd exchanged a glance with Javier and rushed toward the stern. He threw something in the air. Three huge summon creatures appeared in the air.

“Ppodong!”

“Bangul!”

“Hamang!”

Jumbo Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang dove into the sea. They were followed by Lloyd and Javier, who leaped on the back of Bangul.

“All right, everyone! Before we leave, rescue as many people as possible in the water!”

“Ppo!” “Bang!” “Ha!”

Bangul, who was carrying Lloyd and Javier, as well as Ppodong, and Hamang hurried. They saved the people in the area flailing their arms in the water. Once they rescued the elderly, Lloyd got Ppodong and Hamang small again and put them back into his embrace. He started moving toward the city.

“Hey, Bangul.”

“Bangul?”

“Let’s go!”

Lloyd patted Bangul’s side several times. Bangul, who drank seawater, shook her tail. Some seconds after the clear ringing of the bell, a massive

explosion took place from her behind.

The volcanic eruption skill was activated. The gas belched out, hitting the waves hard. The repulsive force thrust Bangul’s body forward against the water. Her body was sent almost flying on the water like a missile in the air or a banana boat cutting the waves.

In a flash, Lloyd and Javier distanced themselves. That was when the count was jostled out of his reverie.

“Everyone! Bring me the ropes! Captain! Move your crew! Quickly!”

Now wasn’t the time to space out. They needed to use this time to rescue people. The count threw off his cumbersome coat. He commandeered the captain and crew members, shouting at the top of his lungs. Thus, the long, tiring, and disastrous night began.

* * *

The orange sky of the dusk was slowly fading, giving way to darkness. As if to drive out the darkness, however, a blaring noise was sounded in the air. A cannon belched fire.

About 5.5 inches in diameter, the twenty-pound metal marble flew in the air at the speed of 408 m/s. It flew across the dark sky over the sea and hit the target. There was motion energy of about 600kJ in the hit.

However, the target simply flinched when it received a blow. It felt a small itch. The Gigatitan shook its head when its forehead was hit with a culverin cannonball. The injured area was itchy, and it continued to be so for a long time.

The coastline was occupied with several posts, and each of the large culverins built for coastal defense belched out fire. The dark cannon balls flew to knock down the monster’s body. Of course, no damage came from it. The cannon balls were not nearly strong enough to penetrate the monster’s shell composed of dentin and chitin. They failed to even lay a scratch on it.

The monster roared aloud. It wasn’t long before it made its way inland. The waves split. The monster walked on the coast, creating an onrush of waves. Six pairs of centipede-like legs walked on the coastal rocks. They crushed one of the posts.

“Everybody, run!”

The soldiers protecting post twenty-three of the Cremo coast yelled as they struggled to not get crushed under the falling post.

The post commander shouted, “Everyone, out! Run!”

The middle-aged post commander shoved the soldiers out to the open lot. Unlike his outcry, the commander didn’t evacuate. He simply remained alone in the post after sending his men out. He looked through the destroyed post roof and stared at the monster.

My mission is to protect this place. Did you think I’d let you go so easily?

The commander quickly grabbed a flaming torch. The floor beside him was littered with powder kegs. The commander hurled the torch toward the kegs, and after making sure that no one was left behind in the post, he rushed out. He sprinted as far as he could with all his remaining strength.

Meanwhile, in the post, the fire touched the kegs. Post twenty-three exploded with a loud roar. The cannons, cannon balls, and brick walls crumbled to countless shards and flew out in the air. The impact tapped the lower body of the Gigatitan.

“Hahaha! How do you like that?!” The commander, who just barely managed to avoid being engulfed by the explosion, shouted.

He glared at the Gigatitan as he wielded his fists.

This must have given it enough damage!

The commander thought it was obvious. After all, every bit of the gunpowder stored in the post blew up. The explosion happened right under its body. So it would have been a hard blow to any living organism.

It’s an explosive bomb! It’s entirely different from cannonballs!

The hard shell had to have been burned by the fire and shattered into a myriad of pieces. Therefore, the monster wouldn’t dare step another foot into the city...

The Gigatitan looked down below. Then, it shook off its ninth leg. The fire on the end of its toe was instantly put out. It was over. The Gigatitan resumed moving again as if nothing had happened and it didn’t have a single wound.

The eyes of the commander of post twenty-three trembled. He could not believe it. Even while he was lost in his daze, the mammoth body of the Gigatitan continued to stride ahead. The commander felt like he was having an unimaginable nightmare.

What was happening in front of his eyes was real. Those giant eyes of the Gigatitan that stared at the busiest area of Cremo city were real. Its movement toward the mermaid statue stuck at the plaza spire was real as well, and so were the unprotected citizens and his family despite the impending danger.

This is nuts!

The commander of post twenty-three gritted his teeth. His family was in the city district. His wife, who finally succeeded in bearing a child after ten hard years of trying, was there as well. Now, the monster was closing in on the very place where his wife was.

I must stop it, come hell or high water.

The commander’s eyes gleamed with determination. He lowered his body. He picked up a rock. He ran forth. He threw it high.

“You bastard! Stop there!” he shouted.

He hurled a rock again. He didn’t care whether it reached the monster. He didn’t care whether it failed to do any damage. Even if it meant he would be

killed here, his goal was to stop the monster or stall it by at least a few seconds. He believed that those few seconds could save his wife.

“Stop! Stop right there!”

He yelled on and on. He hurled a stone, one after another. Maybe it was the working of his determination, but just then, the Gigatitan stopped dead in its tracks like a miracle. Then its giant head creaked as it turned toward his side.

“Grrr?”

“Ha, haha...”

Their eyes locked. The commander let out a pathetic laugh. Then he saw one of the monster’s ginormous feet lift up high right over him. He grimaced.

I’m going to die.

He clenched the stone hard in his hand. He stared at the incoming foot.

Just then, “Hamang!”

All of a sudden, out of nowhere, a giant 196-foot water balloon, no, a hippopotamus hurled his body to whack the Gigatitan in its side.

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Chapter 70: A Runaway and a Fighter (2)

“Hamang!”

A giant water balloon, no Hamang, hurled himself into the air and attacked the side of the Gigatitan.

Hamang was heavily bloated after gulping down the seawater. His weight reached hundreds of tons. Of course, his weight was incomparable to the Gigatitan, which weighed over 2,500 tons. However, it was enough to make the monster stagger.

The Gigatitan’s legs tripped over one another. Like a tap dancer suddenly staggering by a gym ball from the side, the monster stumbled to balance itself without falling down. That saved the commander of post twenty-three.

The leg that was about to trample on the commander was pushed to the side by a few feet. It drove deep into the earth as it smashed a rock. The impact showered the commander with several fragments, but he didn’t get hurt. He was unhurt because he had a protector.

“Get down!”

A shadow appeared to protect him right after the shout was heard. The man seemed to lift something flat high up, and he began brandishing in a grand manner. Soon, sparks of fire bounced off in all directions. A flash of light was emitted from the object in the dark, which allowed him to see his surroundings clearly.

Someone was wielding a shovel. And the man was standing in a strange posture the commander had never seen before as he grabbed the shovel with both of his hands.

But there was something extraordinary about his movement. He was like an arrow that was directly hitting its target. He blocked every piece of rock that flew in his way. The man ruthlessly whacked, blocked, bounced, and pushed the rocks with his shovel.

He’s like... a shield with a handle.

That was what the commander thought of the scene. At last, the shovel handler turned around.

“Are you alright?”

“Uhm, I-I...”

“You looked fine. Please follow me.”

The man was no other than Lloyd, and he spoke to the commander as he slung the shovel over his shoulder. The dazed commander trailed Lloyd.

“Where are we going?”

“Where do you think? We’re running away.”

“Excuse me?”

“Didn’t you hear me?” asked Lloyd. “We’re running away.”

Lloyd’s voice dripped with casualness. The commander’s face hardened.

“I cannot run away. I must protect this place,” replied the commander.

“But you won’t be able to.”

“Still, I have to protect this place.”

“You don’t have to.”

“Eh? What do you mean...”

“Because I will protect this place for you.”

Lloyd, running on his feet, pointed toward one side. The gaze of the commander traced Lloyd’s finger. He spotted fire that was developing all over the destroyed post, where the pile of ammunition had blown up.

Amid the plume of fire stood tall Javier, the silver-haired knight. He was holding only one object in his hand: a long sword. Confidence reeled off him as not a single lash of his eyelid quivered in the face of the giant monster who was dozens of times larger than his body. Instead, he raised his sword high and aimed at the monster. He leaped from the ground.

He charged forward like a tornado. Leaping over the rocks, he jumped over the blazing fire. Right in front of it, there was the eleventh leg of the Gigatitan. Javier brushed past its leg. His sword became a ray of light, sweeping its leg.

Sparks gave off from the friction. A tiny scratch appeared at the end of its leg. Javier's eyebrow quivered after pulling his sword back.

It wasn't slashed?

He had expected that at least half of its leg would be sliced in half. However, his attack rendered a different result.

One more time.

The mana of the manaheart fluctuated. The rotation power of the triple circle shot up. Javier's movement became faster.

Javier moved too fast for the Gigatitan's gaze. He rushed into the monster's blind spot and he jumped and stepped on its leg. He used the kick to leap up to its knees. That part looked vulnerable and defenseless compared to the rest of it.

Javier's sword glimmered. Cutting across the space, he thrust his sword into the leg joint. However, he failed to slash the shell.

The sword attack, which was loaded with the mana blast, bounced off. When his attack was repulsed, the silver-haired knight's eyes were filled with surprise. Lloyd, who had run away prior and just turned around, grimaced instantly.

Oh, come on, Javier. I told you we shouldn't fight.

Lloyd’s heart pounded aloud. Just then, he recalled what happened earlier in the day.

* * *

“All right! Bangul.”

“Bangul?”

“Eat this.”

“Banguuul?”

“It’s a blue sunflower seed. Hurry before the monster notices you.”

Lloyd held out the blue sunflower seed to Bangul. This had taken place right after they swam through the sea on Bangul and safely arrived at the shore. First, Lloyd downsized Bangul. He gave a quick scan of his surroundings.

“What do you plan on doing now?” asked Javier seriously.

Lloyd replied matter-of-factly, “What else? We’ve got to hide.”

“Excuse me?”

Javier slightly furrowed his brows.

“By hide, do you mean ambush the monster?”

“No.”

“Then what do you mean?” asked Javier.

“Ambush? Why would we ambush anyone? We need to hide.”

“Excuse me?”

“Hold on, are you thinking of fighting that monster?”

“Well, of course…”

“Don’t even try. You’re going to get beaten and die.”

Lloyd threw off the tuxedo that had become heavy from being drenched in water. He continued to speak as if he couldn’t wrap his head around why this conversation was even taking place.

“This place isn’t our city. Besides, they have armed forces here. So why on earth should we fight with a gun, no, sword?”

“Um, well...”

“For justice? Something like that?”

Lloyd cocked his head to the side. Javier’s furrow deepened.

“Then what did you mean when you shouted earlier?”

“When did I shout?”

“You replied that you would go yourself when the count had asked you what your plan was now.”

“Yeah, I did shout that.”

“Then why are you not taking responsibility for your words?”

“I said that I’d come here. I didn’t tell him what I’d do after getting here.”

“Right? So, who cares if I go hide now? Why should I put my life on the line for someone else?”

“But, Master Lloyd…”

“Do you think I’m a Superman?”

“Eh? Superman? What do you mean...”

“What, do I look like a hero who’s going to save the world?”

There was no way Javier saw him that way. Lloyd had never thought of himself like that either. He wasn’t Superman nor a hero in a movie who could perform extraordinary feats.

I’m just a normal guy who wants to pay off his debt and live the rest of his life in peace.

He was nothing but a hardworking young man who lived every day to achieve such a goal in mind. He worked hard to win business contracts and make money. An ordinary, hardworking man. That was what Lloyd was.

“Fighting that monster that’s as big as a building? Do you even hear yourself?”

The monster had sent the large statue hundreds of feet in the air with just one blow. It destroyed five sailboats by bumping into them just once. Dozens of cannon balls hit it, only to not even lay a scratch.

Fighting that monster?

Lloyd would have tried if he had stood a chance, but every fiber of his being said that it was impossible. In all frankness, Lloyd was scared. He couldn’t even muster the courage to try.

So, he concluded that what cannot be done cannot be changed, though it was painful to imagine the harm the monster would cause to the people. To Lloyd, the encouraging words to fight the monster as a group sounded the same as a suicide pact.

Lloyd thus spoke. “Let me be very clear. I do not intend to fight. That’s why I spewed some vague words and got out of the sailboat. Now, I will find somewhere safe to hide. I will hide until this chaos calms down a bit.”

“Then what do you plan on doing after the situation settles down?” asked Javier.

“Well, obviously, the count needs to pay me.”

“Once I get the payment for the project, I’m done. Yeah, yeah, I know, this is cunning and sly. However, my hands are tied. There’s nothing I can do. What do you expect me to do here? What more can I possibly do?”

Lloyd argued that there was nothing he could do. Javier’s gaze turned icy as he looked at Lloyd. The words that came out of his mouth were equally icy.

“Is this the kind of person you were all the time, Master Lloyd?”

“What?”

“I am disappointed.”

That was the end. Javier turned around. He drew his sword. He asked Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang, who were all befuddled as to how to act during the argument.

“Do you wish to fight with me?” asked Javier.

“Ppodong!”

“Bangul!”

“Hamang!”

The three summons nodded in unison. A faint smile of satisfaction spread across Javier’s face.

“Great. Shall we go?”

“Ppo!”

“Bang!”

“Ha!”

Javier hugged the three creatures and ran off. They quickly disappeared into the distance.

Just then, messages cascaded in front of his eyes.

[Javier Asrahan is deeply disappointed in you.]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has decreased by five points.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: plus one]

[The intimacy level with Javier Asrahan has decreased one level from <Average Regard> to <Everyday Strangers>.]

[Even though your relationship with the major character has worsened a little bit, your RP remains unchanged and will not be forfeited.]

[Current RP: 1901]

It appeared that Javier was indignant this time. Lloyd bit his lip.

This is nuts.

He didn't want himself or Javier to fight the monster. Of course, Lloyd understood that Javier was strong. However, none of this was in *The Knight of Blood and Iron* he had read.

In the novel, Javier never fought this Gigatitan. Moreover, he wasn't a sword master like in the novel. Even though he had the triple circle with him, technically speaking, he was still a high-level sword expert. This meant that he could meet his end if he got unlucky and recklessly charged forward in the name of justice.

That can't happen.

Lloyd didn't want to lose Javier like that. Was it because he liked Javier?

Of course not.

Why? It's simple. He's the most useful person here!

Javier was set to become his biggest asset. His talent would become the backbone of the fiefdom's prosperity once he was a sword master. On top of that, he was a great equipment for construction at the moment. His mana blast had made quarrying and boring holes in the ground extremely easy.

Plus, I don't have to pay for his labor!

Lloyd needed to just feed him, and he'd work like a mule. So Lloyd didn't want to lose such versatile construction equipment like this by throwing him into danger.

That was why… *Oh, come on! You have no idea how hard I worked to make you strong!* Lloyd ran after Javier, grumbling countless times in his head. He tried to talk Javier out of it. One thing led to another, and that was how Lloyd ended up saving the commander of post twenty-three. Lloyd lashed out at Javier as he ran away with the post commander.

"Hey! That's enough! Let's run away!"

"No, thank you."

Javier, who had already landed on the other side, casually rejected him as he ran in the same direction. The veins on Lloyd's forehead popped out of his skin.

Lloyd bellowed, "Hey!"

"Yes, Young Master."

"Does this turn you on? Do you have a hero kink or something?!"

"Excuse me?"

"Excuse me, my ass! Am I wrong? You really think you can stop it?"

"I don't know. But..."

Javier, who was running at full speed, stopped. He then turned around. The giant monster was charging toward his way. Its foot was shooting down

from the sky. Javier positioned his sword toward the incoming foot and used the mana blast.

Javier's body was sent back along with the fierce shockwave. He was pushed about sixty feet back. Barely recovering his balance, Javier's eyes blazed with determination.

"It appears there is no one who can stop that thing other than me." His voice was soft, but it rang aloud by the mana.

"Wow."

Gosh, he sure acts like he's the main character of the novel. His meddling and sense of justice are unhealthy at this point.

Lloyd didn't have the time to blame it on that nor to dissuade him.

"Hey! Dodge!"

Javier must have been annoying the monster with his mana blasts. The Gigatitan started to shower Javier with attacks. It wielded its club-like forearms, its main weapon.

Javier quickly dodged the attack. A string of attacks followed, giving no time to rest for Javier.

Each time its forearm struck down, the ground cracked, and the rocks turned to powder. The formidable shockwave and pieces of rocks shook the whole area. Javier closely managed to avoid the attack each time. He became farther from Lloyd and drew the Gigatitan to his side.

It appeared that Javier was worried that Lloyd would get hurt by the attack that was meant for him.

That idiot!

Javier was drawing all the attention to himself. It looked like he wanted to die. Lloyd's heart pounded harder as a result.

This is the reason why I said we should hide instead of fight.

However, it was too late to pull out. Lloyd needed to come up with something, otherwise, Javier would be done for. If he was unlucky, Lloyd himself would be dead as well, like a combo deal.

I can't let that happen.

Lloyd shook his head hard. He strove to calm himself.

First, I need to analyze my surroundings if I want to overcome this situation.

He wiped off the drops of sweat streaking down his eyes, and he quickly scanned the area.

He collected his thoughts

.

The biggest problem is that Javier isn't doing any damage to the monster.

Javier could slash through steel, but at the moment, his sword strike wasn't working against the monster's thick shell.

The Gigatitan looks just like a mantis shrimp. Or a lobster with club-like forearms.

The biggest problem of crustaceans was their hard, sturdy, distinctive shell.

Javier might be able to do something if he can get through its skin.

Lloyd looked into the Gigatitan's body.

The night was too dark. Furthermore, it was difficult for him to find the gigatan's weak spot no matter how many times he scanned the monster.

Oh, how I wish that thing was a rock or a ground so I could get a full scan of its shallow layer... Wistfulness flooded his thoughts. Just then, Lloyd was

struck with an epiphany.

Eh? Hold on.

Lloyd, who was sighing at length, paused. A new idea hit him. His fragmented thoughts exploded into a fully developed plan.

Survey. The skill that surveys the ground. The skill that sees which part of the ground is solid and weak. That sweet skill analyzes all geographical features of the land up to sixteen feet underground. But will it work against that thing?

He wondered if that could be possible. Surveying a live organism was something he never tried before. He had never expected it to work. On the off chance that it was... It'd be an amazing win for him. Even if it failed, he'd lose nothing. This was a bet he couldn't lose.

Let's give it a try. Survey!

Lloyd squeezed his eyes in excitement. Activating the surveying skill, he looked up at the Gigatitan.

[Surveying will begin.]

Along with an unbelievable message, various data points of the Gigatitan's body parts appeared in front of him.

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Chapter 71: Attack the Weak Point (1)

[Surveying will begin.]

Lloyd's eyes widened. He looked at the message that popped right in front of him. He had his doubts. However, it was working. It truly worked.

Wow, I never expected this would work.

This wasn't the time to be impressed. This wasn't the time to ponder why on earth this skill worked on the monster. He could be impressed later. He wouldn't miss out on anything if he analyzed why it worked later.

Right now, it's time for me to make good use of it.

Ask later, use now. Lloyd focused on the message that popped right in front of him. His eyes moved rapidly.

Every spot his gaze touched turned into augmented reality. Every inch of the large Gigatitan's body was scanned, analyzed, and turned into a data point in front of him. Lloyd felt like he was using a microscope to look over every single one of the Gigatitan's pores.

Thanks to it, he was able to identify the secret behind the monster's impressive defense power.

Okay, so the survey is done, and its shell is composed of... hmm, chitin and dentin.

It wasn't a simple mix, however. The molecules were intricately structured like a triple-layered honeycomb. Those tripled-layered honeycomb structures were overlapped and woven into a helix. It looked just like a high-end bulletproof vest made of kevlar fiber.

What's more, its average thickness is three feet.

The Gigatitan had naturally possessed a three-foot thick advanced bulletproof vest. That wasn't the only secret behind its defensive capabilities.

There is a subtle wave pattern all over its shell, and it's going in a unified direction.

The pattern mixed together and flowed toward its forehead, which had a giant protruding thorny horn.

Lloyd's gaze sharpened.

That horn doesn't look like a mere decoration.

His gaze sharpened all the more. The wave patterns were concentrated on the horn, but its inside was empty. Lloyd thought that there must be a reason it was there.

Surely, it can't just be a piece of decoration. Maybe this will work as well. Design!

Lloyd activated his design skill. He also activated his skill options.

[Skill Option Three: Simulation mode has been activated.]

[The topographical data of the current virtual design will be available for simulation.]

The background of the virtual space brightened. A plethora of dots and lines floated and connected with one another, like a graphic composed of polygons. A large form appeared in the air.

It was the body of the Gigatitan that was just surveyed.

Okay, it works.

Lloyd's glance traveled to the side. The Gigatitan was jumping all about to catch Javier. It synced perfectly with the one that floated in the simulation mode window.

Just perfect.

Lloyd lifted his two hands. He operated the simulation mode as he touched the air.

What I want to find out is the relationship between the wave patterns on its shell and the empty horn.

Lloyd zoomed in on the screen and focused on one part of the Gigatitan's back.

Then, he bent his finger.

The power of physical impact I want to test is, uhm, about thirty tons.

Lloyd flicked, and the end of his index finger tapped the back side of the Gigatitan displayed in the simulation mode. A force of thirty tons, which Lloyd had just set, was applied.

Lloyd watched the direction of the waves of impact. A red shockwave was created at the center of the impact point. The impact failed to dig deep into the shell. Instead, it flowed and gathered along the wave patterns marked countless times on the surface. After that, it was concentrated on the thorn-shaped horn. Just then, the empty space inside the horn resonated.

This is it. The impact was resonating inside the empty space of the horn. That's why most of the impact settles down into a vibration.

Lloyd's eyes shone. Lloyd was naturally impressed. He felt like he had just witnessed a miracle of nature.

But now's not the time for that.

He wasn't surveying and designing right now to answer his curiosity. He needed to unearth the Gigatitan's weak spot using his skills. Lloyd's gaze became more hectic and tenacious.

Endure for just a little longer, Javier!

Lloyd wouldn’t have been able to use the skill on the monster if Javier hadn’t bought him some time. Knowing this very well, Lloyd ran an experiment on every part of the giant creature. He scanned for its physical characteristics and durability. At last, he was able to find what he was looking for.

There it is.

Narrowing his eyes, Lloyd focused on one point. It was the area that connected the carapaces eleven and twelve in between the space where the monster’s stomach led to its chest.

It’s not accurate to say chest and belly because the Gigatitan is not an insect, but who cares, that part is its greatest weakness.

The test had rendered such a result. It wasn’t that its shell was shallow. It was actually thicker than its back. But once it satisfied two conditions, it held the potential of being destroyed.

The horn and the attack angle. Those two factors are key.

They were the conditions that needed to be met to penetrate its shell. The first job was to get rid of the horn.

That’s how I’ll make sure the impact doesn’t disappear and goes through properly.

Erasing the detailed wave patterns on the shell surface was impossible, but the horn could be discarded. Once the horn was gone, the impact power that flowed along the wave patterns would not resonate through the horn. If it didn't resonate, it would come back to the path it had followed.

The second condition was the angle. The connecting part between the carapaces eleven and twelve. Javier had to thrust from the tail to the head exactly at a forty-five-degree angle. Of course, the blow needed to be hard and mighty.

It will work if Javier uses the mana blast.

With those conditions in mind, Lloyd ran the test three times. Each ended in success. The mana blast had been strong enough to divide the granite bedrock. Penetrating the shell would be easy as long as the conditions are met. He was able to penetrate the dorsal nerve cord and various tissues at the same time.

It's going to leave a critical hit. He can do it.

Lloyd turned off the simulation mode. He lifted up his head. He spotted Javier in the distance, who was losing out to the continuing attacks of the Gigatitan.

Lloyd sprinted in that direction, and about 200 yards away, he shouted at the top of his lungs, "Hey! Can you hear me?!"

Javier didn't answer. It looked like he couldn't hear him.

Oh, crap.

He didn't want to move closer.

But at the same time, he feared that Javier might really die if he stayed like this. Lloyd bit his lips hard.

Ugh, this man and his damned hero syndrome! This is the reason why I never want to be the main character in a novel. No sense of reality whatsoever, seriously.

It was a mystery to Lloyd why Javier decided to fight head-on against such a monster. Why, Lloyd thought to himself, did he volunteer to fight for the strangers? Lloyd was honestly impressed by Javier's spirit. At the same time, the fact that such a hero was his personal knight felt bitter like a cup of espresso.

Crap, really!

Resolved, Lloyd rushed forward. 150 yards... one hundred yards... Lloyd narrowed the distance between him and Javier. At last, he entered the shadow of the Gigatitan that heavily fell over him.

He shouted very loudly, “Hey! Dude!”

This time, he heard a response. The voice wasn’t a shout. It was soft and yet clear as if Javier had used his mana to speak.

“Master Lloyd?”

“Yeah! It’s me, you punk!”

“Do you plan to fight the monster with me?”

Lloyd seemed to catch a slight sense of gladness in his voice. Shuddering, Lloyd retorted, “Fight with you, my ass! Why would I do such a thing?!”

He paused for a second before continuing to speak.

“You’re all jittery because you can’t lay even a scratch on its shell no matter how much you slash and stab it, eh?”

“No.”

“No?”

“No, Young Master,” Javier said.

“Why?”

“I was attacking the horn first, not its body.”

“What...?”

Dazed, Lloyd lifted his head. The Gigatitan’s shadow fell over them, and Lloyd caught a glimpse of its head over its giant body. To Lloyd’s surprise, its horn was cut in half!

“This is just my gut feeling, but I feel like that horn is working to dissipate my blow. So, I intend to cut the horn first.”

“Wow.”

Javier’s voice was calm. But contrary to his composed voice, he moved like a storm. Seeing that, something struck Lloyd to his core.

This is what a true prodigy looks like.

Javier was truly different as he was set to become the one and only grandmaster in history. It had taken using the analysis and surveying skill for Lloyd to discover the monster’s weak spot. But Javier managed to pinpoint it in the process of fighting against it head-on.

“Then, did you also figure out that the monster has a weak spot on its belly?”

“No,” Javier replied, “I did not know that.”

“That’s why I am here!”

Lloyd shouted triumphantly. Whatever the case was, the only person who could drive into the weak spot was Javier. And so, it was imperative for Lloyd to tell him about its weak spot.

That was the only way for him and Javier to make it out of there alive. Lloyd’s shout was immediately returned with a response.

“I wish to hear more about it.”

Javier landed right beside Lloyd. He unilaterally stretched out his hands.

“So please excuse me for a moment,” he added.

“Eh?”

Javier grabbed Lloyd by the back of his neck and jumped off the ground. The movement made Lloyd feel like he was riding on top of a high-speed train.

Lloyd snapped his eyes open. His feet felt detached from the ground. The ground swooshed past him at that moment. The stormy noise of the wind

beat his ears. Lloyd couldn't lift his head because of the mighty wind. Right above him was the Gigatitan, attacking them!

The rocks in the cliffs were being destroyed and crumbling, and the shards fell from the sky like rain. Javier charged forth like a storm in between. Dangling in the air like a popsicle wrapper, Lloyd shrieked when he was being hoisted in the air only by Javier's grip on his collar.

"Aaack! Hey!! What's this? Do you have something against me?!!"

"Yes, I do. Why ask such an obvious question."

"Please be more specific about the monster's weak spot."

"Argh! Can we talk after you let go?"

"I'm doing this because I'm nervous that I'll mishear if I stay far from you."

"Aaack! Dammit!"

Javier kept drastically shifting their direction and moving faster.

Striving hard to not vomit, he shouted, "It's just what I explained to you a while ago! It's the space between the carapaces eleven and twelve that connects the chest and belly. Do you see that?"

"Yes, I can."

"From the tail to the head! Stab the center point at a forty-five-degree angle! Use your mana blast!"

"Will that work?"

"Probably. But you have to cut that horn first!"

"Yes, Young Master."

Javier didn’t inquire where Lloyd got the information. He didn’t have the time to waste his time on trivial questions. Right now, they needed to trust each other.

“Then please stay here.”

Javier finally let go of his grasp after he landed. Lloyd’s nape, which was continually shackled, was finally liberated. Javier leaped once again.

With that, Lloyd was left alone in between the rocks of the coastal cliff. He stared at the back of Javier, who was going back to hurtle toward the Gigatitan. Afterward, he thought to himself. Regardless of when he saw it, Javier’s combat style was an art form.

One of the Gigatitan’s feet stomped on the ground. It meant to aim at Javier, who was charging forward. He was already gone as he had leaped high. He was actually “flying,” using the Gigatitan’s leg as a spring.

He kicked the pillar-like leg and shot up like a flash of light. Then, he used his sword to whack another leg joint that tried to block his movement, leaving the repulsion power of the weapon’s aura to take control of his body.

The impact made him fly out sideways, and he used the mana blast downward. After slightly getting elevated, he gave his body a twist. Five appendages of the Gigatitan rushed toward him all at once, but he simply slid past and avoided them. When he finally climbed up its back, he sprinted forward.

Javier quickly charged toward the monster’s head like a gust of wind or a lightning bolt coming down from the sky. Before the Gigatitan could shake its body, Javier leaped in the air and transferred his energy to his sword. It was added along with the rotation power as he twisted to the right midair.

He brandished his sword and gave a slash. The area he stabbed had already received dozens of hits in the same angle and direction. His blade shone coldly and dug right into the spot again. Right as the blade seemed to brush past the horn...The horn was cut off the Gigatitan’s forehead.

“Grrrrrr!”

The Gigatitan, now infuriated, flung its body toward Javier. However, Javier had already landed and shifted his direction. As the monster charged ahead in a fury, the whole ground was overturned.

Javier, having closely avoided the attack, sprinted. He stepped only on the peak of the protruded and overturned ground. His eyes glimmered again.

Right over there.

He spotted the weak point Lloyd had shown him. Moving as swiftly as the wind, he jumped right into the large body of the Gigatitan.

Got it.

Javier needed to be at a forty-five-degree angle from the monster’s head. Keeping that in mind, he fixed his sword high. He created a collision from the mana circles and pointed his sword. Mana blast. Right before the blast could dig into the Gigatitan’s weakness…

Out of nowhere, Javier was swept over by the powerful storm from the left. It was the Gigatitan’s forearm.

“Tsk!”

Javier redirected the direction of the blast by reflex toward the rushing forearm. The two powers, the strong forearm club and the powerful mana blast, crashed together in the air.

*J*avier’s body was sent flying by the explosion. His body took a nosedive and got stuck in the ground.

“Argh!”

His foot dug into a rock. But he didn’t have any time to waste.

The forearm club struck down again much more fiercely than it did previously. Javier immediately jumped, but the rock became crushed to

dust. Javier then attempted a counterattack amid the sandstorm of broken rocks. He laser-focused on the Gigatitan's weak spot. The monster was doggedly protecting its weak spot. This was a fight between the silver-haired knight, who was about to become a sword master, and a monster that was the size of a high-rise building. The two gave their all fighting each other.

Lloyd was about one hundred yards away, watching the battle.

Ha, he'll lose at this rate.

Lloyd thought that Javier would die if he left him alone. So, it was harder for Lloyd to give up and leave now. For some reason, he thought he needed to do something to make sure that Javier would be able to attack the thing's weak spot.

So today, my job is to draw its attention here.

Drawing attention. He needed to bait the monster. Lloyd wondered what would be the best way to do so. He turned his head. He looked around. Just then, the city district of Cremo appeared in his view. In the corner of the plaza, Lloyd vaguely took a glimpse of the mermaid statue stuck in the spire.

That was what got the Gigatitan to frenzy in the first place, right?

After the mermaid statue was thrown toward the city, the monster ended up treading into the land to lay another attack. What would, Lloyd wondered, happen if the mermaid statue started happily dancing in front of the Gigatitan?

His eyes wouldn't be on Javier.

Lloyd chuckled. He remembered one of the most important rules he had learned by playing video games in Korea. What was the best way to draw attention? It was to pester and annoy his opponent until they insulted his gameplay.

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Chapter 72: Attack the Weak Point (2)

“Move! Move!!”

“I’m here, help me out!”

“There’s a fire!”

“Start helping from over there! Everyone, move!”

The night had been a typical one. Everyone had finished working for the day. They returned home and ate dinner with their family. They were finally resting at home after a long day.

It was just another ordinary night in Cremo City. That would have been true if it was a normal day.

Today, however, was different. A catastrophe seemingly dropped from the sky. It was a crumbling mermaid statue that had appeared out of thin air. When the destructive mishap torpedoed the city, the normal lives of the people crumbled to dust. Thus began the disastrous night.

“I’m here! My leg is stuck! Someone get me out!”

“Hold on for a second. I’m going to get some help!”

All hell broke loose near the plaza. People under the crushed buildings shouted for their lives. Saving them proved to be a difficult job. It was because of the fire. At first, it was only an ember that spilled out of a furnace of a building. However, splinters of wood and furniture littered the area, and the fire quickly spread to them and developed into a fierce blaze in no time. The blaze then engulfed the building and started to spread, which eventually became a large fire.

“Fire!”

“Bring the water! Water!”

Civilians and guards moved hurriedly, panting. They cleaned up the debris in the building, rescued people, and brought buckets of water. The sea wind and dry winter climate made the rescue difficult.

The fire, once caught on, was tenacious. It drifted along the dry wind and spread in a flash. It was useless no matter how many buckets of water were poured over the fire. The speed at which the fire spread was much faster than the speed at which it was being put out. At this rate, it was likely that the blaze would spread across the entire city district.

“Battalion one. Focus on the rescue efforts near the plaza. Are Battalions Two and Three still not here?”

“They’re gathering up.”

“They’re late. We should be constructing the firebreak right now,” said the guard commander of the city as he gritted his teeth.

The situation was bad. It was getting worse every hour.

This is an emergency. We can’t handle this.

His lips dried. The situation was that desperate.

Why is the wind this strong today out of all days? The fire can’t be contained. And the majority of the soldiers in the force are serving the lord at sea and aren’t coming back.

The blazing fire couldn’t be contained. The guards, who were in charge of putting them out, weren’t moving as smoothly as he wanted. It was because the commanders of small units had gotten on the sailboat with the count. Making things worse, the situation outside the city was gloomy as well.

No, it was worse than gloomy. It was transcendentally despairing.

That monster has climbed up to the land... Just outside the city was the cliff near the coast. Every time he turned to look there, he felt as if he was stuck in a nightmare. The 295-foot monster could be vaguely seen, and it was going berserk under the moonlit night sky. It was the Gigatitan.

The growl, low and threatening as if it was scratching the ground, blared clearly even from where he stood. It tapped his eardrums as if it was rushing in his direction.

If that monster gets here... We're done for.

He could ascertain it. The city was already in chaos due to the fire. If the Gigatitan came here and wrecked havoc once again, the damage would be tremendous. The guards and the count's army could sacrifice their lives to protect the city, but that might not be enough.

And yet, there's no news from the lord. Who knows if the monster has gotten the better of him already? The fate of my city... Is this how it falls tonight?

A shadow of despair hung over his heart. With a serious gaze, he looked at the city district. He stared at the spreading fire that started from the plaza and moved into the city district. So, he was able to see it. He saw the blaze of fire expanding. He saw the night sky glowing red. A giant pinkish water balloon shot down from the sky.

"Hamang!"

Hamang shouted and opened his mouth wide at the same time. More than 26,000 gallons of seawater gushed out of him.

The seawater splashed against the air resistance across the sky and split into hundreds and millions of droplets. The water sprayed over the plaza and the entire city district. It was like a local torrential fall. With just one move, the fire that blazed across the city district was extinguished. The spark that was starting to spread to the next building was instantly killed as well, and the heat that burned the pillars and roofs cooled at once. Hamang, now reduced to the size of a fist, fell down from the sky and landed on Lloyd's palm.

"Hamang!"

"Good job."

Lloyd stroked Hamang. He had wondered if this would work. He had wondered if Hamang would be able to leap from outside of the city and above the city district when he held so much seawater. It turned out that he had worried for nothing. Hamang was much more capable than Lloyd thought he was. His body bounced like a ball even when it hit the ground several times.

“You did a very good job. You saved a lot of people today,” said Lloyd.

“Hamang!”

After stroking him once more, Lloyd put him back into his inner pocket. Lloyd then shouted.

“Run faster, Ppodong! Let’s go!”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong galloped faster as he carried Lloyd on his back. He cut across the main road, jumped over the dried fish store, and passed through the plaza. Finally, he saw.

He saw the spire that stood tall at one side of the plaza. The mermaid statue was stuck on its side. Lloyd immediately directed Ppodong toward the foot of the spire.

He then shouted, “Ppodong! Pluck it out!”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

Ppodong jumped right then, using the momentum he got from running with Lloyd. Then, he grabbed the mermaid statue that laterally protruded from the spire and dangled on it. He tensed his forearms as he wiggled his chubby butt.

The mermaid statue that was stuck deep into the building was plucked out. Lloyd’s eyes shone. The mermaid statue was badly smashed and broken, and its messed up state wasn’t anything surprising given that it flew all the way here after Gigatitan hit it.

Its outline and silhouette were somewhat visible. Lloyd spotted the broken head and two arms lying around in the area.

“Alright, can you carry this?”

“Ppodong!”

To Lloyd’s relief, Ppodong could carry the giant mermaid statue that was bigger than his body without any problem. Lloyd was also relieved that he could carry the two arms himself, though it was a bit of a struggle.

“Alright, let’s go!”

“Ppodong!”

They dashed off, leaving the plaza. He was a little worried about the people left behind at the plaza, but his hands were tied. Extinguishing the fire took care of the most urgent issue, so the rest of the rescue efforts would be manageable for the rest of the guards and people. Believing that, he directed Ppodong.

“Over there! To the shipbuilding yard!”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong shifted as Lloyd motioned. The shipyard was where he built the Caisson needed for constructing the artificial ground in the water. So he was used to the path as he frequented it to give out orders and look over its progress. Thanks to that, he arrived at the shipyard in no time. There, he easily found the object he had in mind.

I think a large cart was always put up over there... Yes. Found it.

Lloyd’s eyes shone. The shipyard had an especially large cart that carried ginormous logs or small ships to the sea from the land. The thick wheel spindles were designed to bear the massive weight of the cart. There were six wheels in total, and they were as tall as a human. Because of its sheer size, Cremo City, despite its riches, could only own two carts.

“Hey, Ppodong. Over there!”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

Lloyd pointed at the cart, and Ppodong started moving as he caught on to what he meant. Ppodong put the mermaid statue he was carrying on top of the cart. The cart tumbled once, but all was good as the monstrous cart successfully bore the weight of the statue.

Right afterward, Lloyd began to perform an emergency surgery on the statue.

Okay, it has to be as real as possible. It’s gotta look real in the eyes of the Gigatitan.

He had brought enough of the ropes for docking and tightly wrapped them around the statue’s body.

Next, he connected the two amputated arms. Its two arms were broken by joints, which meant that it was cleanly divided into sections of shoulder, elbow, and wrist. Lloyd connected all of them using the rope. The connected joints dangled like a nunchuck. The broken neck was connected in a similar fashion, but it was tightened harder than the arms. It was tightened just enough for a slight tilt and thus, the makeshift mermaid statue was completed.

It looks realistic.

This would allow the joints connected with the ropes to limply move each time the cart rattled. Somehow, it looked more real than when it wasn’t smashed apart.

Next, I gotta put it up like this... Whew!

Thankfully, the cart was designed for the bottom to have a slight slope, just like how modern dump trucks would push out the soil by tilting their open-box bed downward.

The device allowed the logs and other cargo to be spilled all at once. Lloyd turned the lever up and down without rest. The device made a squealing noise each time he turned it. The ground of the container began to slope. As a result, the mermaid statue was made to rise up on its own. At last, the corners of Lloyd's lips rose in satisfaction.

This will do.

The angle was perfect. The statue was perfectly slanted in an upright position. Before he finished, he used the rope to firmly tie the body of the statue and cart together. It was meant to hold the statue from falling even when the cart tumbled and shook violently. With that, everything was good to go.

Since the rope can withstand ships weighing hundreds of tons, this should be enough.

Confident in himself, Lloyd tied the rest of the rope around Ppodong's waist, which was loosely connected to the cart.

"Hey, Ppodong."

"Ppodong?"

"Ready to run?"

"Ppodong!" Ppodong's dark eyes were filled with determination.

"Let's go then! Off we go!"

Lloyd tapped Ppodong in the back. His chubby body pushed forward with explosive determination. The ginormous cart got dragged by Ppodong's dominating power.

At first, it was slow, but things started to speed up. After some more acceleration, his speed explosively revved up.

"Let's gooo!"

“Ppodong!”

Rattle! Rattle! Rattle! Dirt flew in the sky each time Ppodong kicked the ground. The cart raced amid the violent storm of dirt. He ran out of the shipyard, and it didn’t take much time for him to leave the city. Ppodong zoomed toward the cliff in the west, where the Gigatitan was at.

“To the front!”

“Ppodong!”

He hurtled toward the Gigatitan’s face. The cart let out a strange noise as it dragged behind Ppodong on the rocky ground. The road wasn’t paved. It was rocky and rough. The cart noisily raced forward like a bumper car. It rattled and clattered and trembled as it moved. The mermaid statue violently rattled with it.

The neck of the statue cocked up and down restlessly. Its two arms flailed like it was doing a body wave. The loud clattering noise prompted the Gigatitan to shift its gaze toward this side. There, it caught sight of what was going on. It saw the mermaid, its nemesis and archenemy. It saw the intimidating mermaid that was unusually large. The mermaid was rushing toward it, fantastically hula dancing at a fast beat.

The Gigatitan shifted immediately. It instantly forgot the enemy it was trying to kill, Javier. That dancing machine mermaid charging toward it was recognized as a bigger threat. The monster reacted like a child rushing to get their hands on a free balloon from a store event or an unemployed person rushing to get a discounted meal combo. It bolted in the direction of the incoming cart, roaring out a ferocious growl. It wielded its giant, club-shaped forearm.

“Turn!”

Lloyd shouted as he pulled Ppodong’s right ear. Understanding his instruction, Ppodong instantly turned to the right. The cart that connected to him with several layers of ropes was turned to the right as well.

A blaring noise rang aloud like a bomb was exploding nearby. Lloyd almost felt the ground shaking. The area was wiped out by one stroke of the Gigatitan, but Ppodong didn't care as he continued to gallop. Lloyd was the same on his back.

I'm so glad that I asked Javier to teach me how to ride horses!

He had learned how to ride the horse on the way to this city. He was able to remain on Ppodong's back even when he galloped off like a wild horse. However, it was too early for Lloyd to be relieved.

"Faster!"

"Ppodong!"

The powerful mermaid statue was doing an impressive hip-hop dance. The sight caused the Gigatitan to pounce on it. Each time it did, Lloyd's heart raced as though he was walking on a burning tightrope.

"A little faster! Run! Javier, hey! Get on with it!"

Lloyd's shout became hurried. He had succeeded in drawing the attention of the Gigatitan. So, it was time for Javier to kill it.

This is exactly the reason why I didn't want to play this role!

Lloyd just wanted to pay off his family's debt. That was why he worked so hard every day. Today as well he had planned to stay quietly hidden all day.

It was beyond him how he ended up in such a risky position. Lloyd blamed his destiny as he let out a sigh that just come out.

It's all because of you and your hero syndrome, Javier!

Lloyd gazed up with his blame-filled eyes as he busily directed Ppodong. He spotted Javier leaping in the air like a ray of lightning.

The Gigatitan had become defenseless as it pursued Ppodong. Javier charged toward its weak spot with a long sword in his arms. Once he was

ready to thrust it upward, he slashed it down at lightning speed. Javier used his ultimate move. The mana blast went off.

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Chapter 73: Attack the Weak Point (3)

The long sword was pointed forward with great force. More mana was added to the sword through his grip. It wasn't ordinary mana that spurted out through the manaheart. This time it was much more explosive and destructive.

The three circles spun around his heart at an incredible speed. They staggered as the rotation power maxed out. One circle wrapped around the heart. The other two collided, creating a fierce blast.

The explosive power raced along his blood vessels. Afterward, it rushed through his body, passed his shoulders, and ran along his arms. Then it jumped into the sword's handle through the end of his fingers. The blade amplified the mana once more. At last, it burst out. It burst out toward the weak spot of the Gigatitan, the area between carapaces eleven and twelve.

The mana blast flew toward its point of weakness. At that moment, Javier's blue eyes glimmered.

It's a success.

The twenty-year-old silver-haired knight was confident. The mana blast could not be any more of a success. Javier's blasting power was delivered perfectly. The hitting spot and angle could not be any more precise. He hit right at the location Lloyd had told him to capitalize. The explosion took place at last.

A destructive power swirled in between the Gigatitan's carapace. It slashed and tore everything that was within the blast range, including the carapace. It dug right in.

The monster screeched, writhing its huge body in agony. The explosive power of the blast drove into the Gigatitan's carapace. It became torn up. It rushed further in. It torpedoed towards the monster's critical point. Then it stopped. It was just two inches short of cracking the shell. That was how much thickness was left. The penetrating power dissipated.

Javier’s eyes widened in disbelief. At the same time, a repulsive power worked from his shoulder, which was the consequence of failing to drive into the shell perfectly.

The influence of the explosive power rushed back to him from the small opening he had dug with his mana blast.

Javier’s sword bounced off. His body jerked violently, and the right shoulder, which gripped the sword, opened wide. The same thing happened to the leg on the other side. His left hand that was grabbing the appendicular of the Gigatitan relaxed by reflex. His hand fell loose, and his body started to fall from the sky. No, he was thrown into the ground because of the repulsive power.

Shoot...

Javier clenched his teeth. He would be hitting the ground soon. That was when it hit him why his blast had failed, why the weak spot of the Gigatitan couldn’t be penetrated. He understood why he lacked the power to blast the said part.

Every condition was perfect. The targeted area and angle were precise. But I lacked one thing. Strength. I must have grown tired without realizing it.

Javier’s suspicions were right. In the first place, Lloyd had run the mana blast simulation with the greatest amount of energy Javier could harness. So, the condition to penetrate the monster’s weak spot would be to use the mana blast with all the power he had.

That was the key to crushing its weakness. He failed to make it happen, and the reason was simple.

I didn’t know my stamina was this bad.

He had been dealing with the Gigatitan for over twenty minutes all by himself, running around without a second of break. He sprinted, turned, leaped, and wielded his sword. Countless rocks hit him, the series of shockwaves making his stomach churn too many times to count.

He fought alone, again and again, enduring the painful agony and damage. As such, it was natural that the fight would take a toll on him.

But that can't be an excuse.

Javier tightened the grip of his sword. He couldn't give up after failing once.

Master Lloyd had trusted me.

Lloyd had taught Javier the weak spot. That wasn't all. His young master was risking himself and keeping the Gigatitan distracted from him so that he could attack its weak spot. So, he had to return the trust he was given. He wanted to.

So, just once more!

Javier turned his body in the air right before he hit the ground. His two feet landed safely on the ground, crushing the earth beneath them. Then he leaped high.

His body shot up in between the crumbling rocks. There was an intense light emitting from his eyes, which were fixed only at one point. The weak spot he had failed to penetrate by two inches.

Just one more thrust!

Javier would be able to penetrate the shell accurately. Then, he would finally pierce the monster's heart which was protected by a shell.

One more time!

Just then, a giant forearm swept over Javier. Javier, who immediately noticed the danger, wielded his sword, but it was too late. His sword and its forearm clashed, creating several fierce sparks. His sword was pushed away and his body was sent flying down. The onrush of force proved to be indomitable, and it was extremely overpowering.

Javier was catapulted into the air even when he was just brushed by the mighty blow of the Gigatitan's forearm. With his consciousness lost, Javier plummeted to the ground like a kite with a cut string. His limp body passed by the coastal rocks and took a nosedive into the shore.

Lloyd let out a shriek as he saw what had happened.

Is he dead?

His heart sank. He had worked so hard to keep him alive. He risked so much danger he couldn't afford.

He can't die like that!

His heart raced. It felt like the blood in his body was cooling down. But the situation was growing worse.

The Gigatitan roared after knocking Javier out with its forearm. It moved on, unobstructed. It moved toward the sandy beach where Javier was plunged into. This only meant one thing.

That monster is definitely trying to kill him.

Though he had failed, he almost succeeded in piercing its weak spot with one blow and had he succeeded in his ruthless second attempt, Javier would have made it.

For that reason... *It currently considers Javier as its greatest threat. That's why it's trying to get rid of him.*

Lloyd didn't know how badly injured Javier was. He wasn't even sure if he was still breathing. But if he was alive... The monster intended to ensure that he was dead.

No. I must stop him.

Lloyd gulped dryly and then hurriedly tapped Ppodong's back.

"Ppodong! Run! You can do it!"

“Ppo-do-dong!”

Ppodong must have been thinking the same as he watched the same scene. He ran at full speed when he was urged by Lloyd. The cart rattled more violently as Ppodong zoomed toward the head of the Gigatitan. Lloyd was creating a ruckus in the open area, but the monster didn’t even turn around.

Dammit!

It looked like it had grown out of the mermaid statue. It looked like killing Javier should come first before dealing with the mermaid. In other words, the attention that was originally focused on the statue had completely shifted to Javier.

What should I do?

Lloyd racked his brain. He could only come up with one conclusion.

“Ppodong! We need to save Javier first! Here we go!”

“Ppodong!”

“Then I’ll cut this rope now, okay?!”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

Lloyd lifted his shovel and wielded it. The rope that connected the cart to Ppodong fluctuated when Lloyd hit it with his shovel. He brandished it several more times.

“Come on! Rip now! Argh!”

After several strikes, the rope began to tear. At last, it was fully torn. The cart loaded with the mermaid statue was left behind when the rope tore. This made Ppodong’s movement lighter and faster.

“Let’s go! We should be faster than the Gigatitan!”

“Ppo-do-do-dong!”

Ppodong’s speed increased now that the load was off. He ran faster than the Gigatitan. He jumped over rocks, got down the cliffs like a gust of wind, and cut across the beach. Javier was lying limp on the beach, his body swaying by the waves. Lloyd rushed on his way. Hanging beside Ppodong’s side, Lloyd stretched out his hand and grabbed Javier’s sleeves.

“Got him!”

He then gave a strong pull and got Javier lying on Ppodong’s back. Javier was still unconscious. First, Lloyd checked if he was breathing.

“He’s alive...!”

“Ppodong!”

Thankfully, Javier was breathing. But it didn’t look like he fractured something. This was a great miracle, given the impact he had received. Or maybe it’s the work of his power.

He must have distributed the impact of the forearm with his sword when it struck him. He’s alive because he avoided the full blow. What a guy, really.

He was still unconscious, but Lloyd felt relieved. Since he wasn’t injured very much, he could only get some rest.

It’s going to be hard just for a few days, but he’ll be alright since he has the triple circle!

It was the same case when he fought against the wild ants. His recuperation was fast. So it’d probably be the same thing today.

“So, let’s get out of here. Ppodong! Run!”

Lloyd thought that he had done his part. Javier was now lying unconscious, so Lloyd no longer wanted to deal with that skyscraper-sized monster.

I have stalled for over thirty minutes already. The city must have had enough time to fight against the giant lobster. Now, I just have to run and hide until things calm down a bit.

Lloyd would simply need to nurse Javier from time to time, and he'd get what he owed from the count after this disaster was kept in check. Then, they would return to the Frontera barony. Thinking such, Lloyd tapped Ppodong's back.

"Let's get out of the beach, Ppodong. Go into the woods!"

That seemed like a smart choice because of the thick woods that would hide their bodies.

However...

"Ppo-do-dong. Ppodong...!" Ppodong panted, letting out strange noises.

Lloyd's heart sank.

"Ppodong?"

"Ppo-do-dong?"

"Wait, are you exhausted?"

"Ppo-do-dong..."

He did notice that Ppodong had slowed down a while ago. The sand seemed to be the cause behind the slow down, but now, Lloyd noticed that Ppodong's breathing had gotten harsher.

He's tired.

It was obvious why. Ppodong had been sprinting while he carried the huge cart and the mermaid statue. Just a while ago, he gave all of his strength to get to Javier before the Gigatitan could. Ppodong was a summoning partner, and yet, it was obvious that he would get tired as he was an animal as well. Making things worse, the Gigatitan wasn't slowing down as it came in his direction!

Dammit!

Lloyd gritted his teeth.

I just had to run. That was it.

However, running away was impossible now. Ppodong's breathing was growing raspy with every moment. His speed was slowing down, and Lloyd could feel it. On the other hand, the Gigatitan was striding across the land as it closed in on them in its mantis shrimp gait, without any sense of fatigue.

At this rate, we'll be caught in a few minutes.

At most, he had five minutes. A feeling of dread began to flood his heart. Lloyd quickly racked his head.

What should I do?

He ran through all the scenarios that he could think of.

Make Bangul giant and get on her back. Use the volcanic blast skill to compromise the vision and run. Make Hamang drink seawater and run toward the sea.

Lloyd came up with various potential plans, but he shook his head at all of them.

No. It's going to fail.

Bangul was only fast when she used the volcanic blast. Her slithering speed was slow because of her short and chubby physique. Even if she could move on the water like a banana boat, she'd be slower than the Gigatitan.

It was the same for Hamang.

I don't have any way to escape. I can't get out of this situation. The monster will catch up to us if I don't give up Javier.

A pessimistic thought intruded his mind. Lloyd's gaze traveled to Javier, who was still unconscious.

Should I leave him?

He pondered for a second. At this very moment, what the Gigatitan wanted was Javier. So abandoning him would allow Lloyd to get out of this place safely. He was sure about that. But he shook his head.

Then Javier will die. I can't let that happen.

Javier was set to become a sword master and protect him. So, losing Javier in a place like this would be a serious loss for him.

I mean, abandoning him is the right choice for my safety at this moment… No. I can't be shortsighted. My gut is telling me that it's a terrible choice.

He didn't want to miss out in the future by making a myopic judgment at the moment. When he thought that way, there was only one method left.

The most doable plan looks like exchanging roles.

Lloyd, who had captured their attention, and Javier, who targeted the vulnerabilities, found it was the moment to swap roles.

Shoot! This is why I told him we should hide instead of fighting!

Lloyd clenched his teeth. Overcome with annoyance, Lloyd slapped Javier's cheek just once. He opened the system window to equip himself with the weapon needed to fight against the Gigatitan.

Right now, I stand zero chance of winning. The only way for me to leave damage on it is to hit the same hole Javier had almost bored with his mana blast.

The only way for him to leave a precise attack on the Gigatitan was the mana blast.

I need at least three circles to use the blast.

Two circles for the collision. One circle to protect the heart from the impact. So, Lloyd decided to make the triple circles.

Let's give it a try. I have enough RP.

Determined, Lloyd selected the skill menu window. The Asrahan Core Technique, the skill he had created in the dark ant cave that plunged him into despair… The time had finally come to upgrade it into a triple circle.

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Chapter 74: Triple Circle (1)

“Grrr!”

Tremble! A loud roar thundered in the air, shaking the ground. Each time it happened, a shadow reflecting against the moon closed in on them. There was a giant silhouette rushing toward them as it blanketed the moonlight and the night sky.

The Gigatitan bellowed as it ran, and Ppodong rushed ahead of it. Ppodong heaved a heavy sigh and took each step forward, his leg feeling heavy. But the distance between the Gigatitan and Ppodong was gradually narrowing. Each time the monster’s leg moved in a queue, its thunderous roaring came closer to him.

We don’t have much time. Lloyd quickly glanced behind. At most, he had three minutes. If he was lucky, he had five.

After that, Ppodong will be caught by the monster. He and Javier wouldn’t be safe, either. Lloyd’s gaze sharpened. *Skill window. The Asrahan Core Technique.* He opened the skill menu and selected the Asrahan Core Technique. The skill information appeared in front of his eyes.

Ding Dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique: Double Circle Lv. 4]

[Mana amplified to: 260%]

[Skill Options: ① Energizer / ② Latent Power Surge / ③ Power Saving Mode]

[Required RP to level up: 190]

[Current RP: 1901]

Great. He had spent quite a lot of RP to level up the Asrahan Core Technique back at the ant cave. And so, he was able to advance to double circle level one. Afterward, he leveled up once again when he filled the ice in the seokbinggo back at the orc village. Finally, after some continuous training in his skills from time to time, he was able to reach the fourth level.

Whew... I hope I have enough RP. Lloyd checked his remaining RP. 1901. He had a feeling that he would need more.

500 RP was enough for me to quickly advance in the past, but now, it isn't going to cut it. He needed to spend a whopping 190 RP just to level up. However, his RP usage would continue to rise as he leveled up more.

Let's just give it a try anyway. There's no other way around it. As such, Lloyd selected the menu below the skill window to level up his Asrahan Core Technique into a triple circle.

[Would you like to invest your RP in the Asrahan Core Technique?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a yes. He didn't have any time to hesitate now. Lloyd nodded right away.

Ding Dong!

[Skill Level Up!]

[The Asrahan Core Technique: Double Circle Lv. 5]

[Mana amplified to: 280%]

[Required RP to level up: 220]

[Current RP: 1711]

Hmm... I've got a bad feeling about this. Several pieces of information appeared in front of him. Lloyd opened and closed his fist a few times as he read them. He quickly calculated the numbers he saw in his head.

I leveled up once, and now I need 30 more RP to level up again. At this rate, hmm... I might need more RP. He had a bad feeling about it. Regardless, the situation didn’t change at all. He still needed to ramp up his number of circles to three, which required him to level up once more after reaching double circle level 10.

The problem was that he might be a tad short on RP. *If the demanded RP continues to go up like this... I might lack 51 RP in the last stage.* But he didn’t have any means to check that in advance. No, there was actually just one way, and it was to continue to level up his skills.

I’ve already begun. I can’t back out now. Don’t know how it will end, but we’ll see! Lloyd was already in a do-or-die situation. Determined, he splurged his RP in the skill. The level of the Asrahan Core Technique continued to go up.

From level five to six. From level seven to eight... From level nine to ten... And the limit was reached.

Ding Dong.

[Skill Level Up!]

[The Asrahan Core Technique: Double Circle Lv. 10]

[Mana amplified to: 380%]

[Required RP to level up: 370]

[Current RP: 319]

“Tsk,” Lloyd clicked his tongue. His ominous gut feelings were never wrong and was proven correct as expected. The predictions he had made in advance turned out to be perfectly accurate.

Whew... Is this for real? The problem was that it was real. Resentment swelled over him.

I had worked so hard to collect RP until now. He had collected every single RP like a wretched miser. He increased his likeability with Javier, the baron couple, and the others, scraping up whatever he could save. He set out to amass various construction projects and accomplishments to earn large amounts of bonus RP.

Each time, a strong impulse to use the RP took over him. But he held back, convincing himself that a day would come where he truly needed it. He believed the asset would become a powerful weapon for him. So, he had worked hard and saved as though he was putting a portion of his income in a 10 or 20-year retirement plan or collecting coupons for a restaurant.

And yet, I don't have enough. Truly, Lloyd thought that it was unfair. But he knew that it wasn't the time to seethe in resentment.

Roar! Grrrr!

Lloyd noticed that the distance between himself and the Gigatitan had narrowed once again. On the other hand, Ppodong was running slower than a while ago. He was getting fatigued. Lloyd had to come up with a plan. His half-baked double circle level 10 wouldn't cut it.

I must level it up to a triple circle. That's how I'll be able to use the mana blast! It was the only possible way for him to drive into the thick carapace of the Gigatitan, and in order for him to make that happen...

RP! I need RP! Now! Lloyd racked his brain in a frenzy. He went over every possible option he had, and at last, he arrived at one conclusion. The young master lifted his hand up with all his might. His palm forcefully slapped Javier, who was unconscious, across the cheek. *Slap!*

Lloyd shouted, "Hey, you! Wake up!"

Slap! Slap! He threw more blows. And this time, he grabbed Javier's collar and shook.

"Wake up! Open your eyes!"

Slap! Slaaap! Lloyd continued slapping one spot on Javier's face. The knight's cheek was flushed red. A few more slaps finally got Javier to squint his eyes open.

"Uhm..."

Javier frowned as if he was in pain. Bemused, he gazed at Lloyd's side.

"Master... Lloyd?"

His voice was soft and feeble. Lloyd's face beamed at once. A welcoming, grateful expression swept over his face.

"Yes, it's me. Do you recognize me?"

"Yes, a little... Argh."

Javier fell back when he tried to rise himself up, panting heavily.

"Don't move."

Lloyd quickly held out his hands and helped Javier lie back down. Then, he tapped the man, who was still harshly panting, on his shoulder.

"You're badly hurt."

"But, Master Lloyd, I..."

"I know," Lloyd said, "that you wish to keep fighting."

"Yes, so I must…"

"No, no. Rest."

"Master Lloyd?"

"If you try to fight now, you're going to die. Do you really want that to happen?"

“Obviously I do. If I don’t do anything, a lot of people will get hurt.”

“What about me? Don’t you care that I’ll be in grief?”

“Excuse me...?”

Javier flinched. Lloyd smiled bitterly.

“If I lose you, I’ll be like an eagle with broken wings.”

“Master Lloyd?”

“To be honest, I don’t want to lose you. I hate to see you overwork yourself like this and try to sacrifice yourself.”

“…….”

“So from now on, fight only for me.”

“But, Master Lloyd, right now…”

“Leave it to me. I’ll pick up the fight from here.”

“Master Lloyd?”

“Do you trust me?”

“I...” Javier trailed off.

“I asked if you trust me.”

This time, Javier was silent. Javier’s eyes traveled up to him, which seemed to be asking him if Lloyd was serious. Lloyd received the gaze with nonchalance. Instead of replying back with words, he simply closed his lips and answered with silence. With a solemn and heavy gaze, Javier nodded.

“Master Lloyd...”

Javier seemed to have felt Lloyd’s sincerity as well. His anxious eyes calmed down. The tension all over his body relaxed. Relieved, he heaved a sigh.

“Then, I will trust you... Master Lloyd...”

“Yes, rest.”

“Yes, Master Lloyd...”

Javier’s eyes closed, and he started to breathe with ease. As his muscles began to relax, Javier passed out again. At the same time, the message Lloyd anxiously waited for floated in front of his eyes. *Ding Dong.*

[Javier Asrahan wholeheartedly trusts your decision and is now relieved.]

[Javier Asrahan is deeply touched by your willingness to fight for a great cause.]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by four points.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: +5]

[You have earned 72 RP by improving relationships with main characters.]

[Current RP: 391]

[Your intimacy level with Javier Asrahan has increased from <Everyday Strangers> to <Average Regard>.]

[You have earned 25 RP as a bonus for the upgrade.]

[Current RP: 416]

Awesome! Lloyd clenched his fists. His operation to cash out RP on the spot worked.

Whew, I have goosebumps all over my body. Lloyd just barely woke Javier up, and the knight was close to falling back unconscious. He didn't have much time left.

That was why he threw every cringey word and expression he could think of to Javier before he passed out again. He had to give everything to hold himself back from vomiting as he spewed those words. The toe-curling cheesiness affected every fiber of his being, but he had to endure it.

But it paid off in the end. Javier completely bought the sugarcoated words Lloyd had thrown, saying that he trusted him before heroically passing out.

Lloyd had improved his likeability with Javier, and not only that... *I received a sum of 97 RP too.* His last hurdle was upgrading to a triple circle. He was held back by his lack of RP earlier, but now, he had enough.

Lloyd opened his skill window and went on to spend his RP without any hesitation. The message he had waited for appeared in front of him. *Ding Dong.*

[Skill Class Level Up!]

This is what I'm talking about! Lloyd cheered in his head. He felt like he had overcome another challenge. He read through the message that popped in front of him.

[Your Asrahan Core Technique class has been increased to <Triple>.]

[Your optional skills have improved following the increase of skill class.]

[The Asrahan Core Technique: Triple Circle Lv. 1]

[Mana amplified to: 500%]

[Skill Option 1: Energizer - Maximizes the efficiency of the double circle. You can move for 20 minutes without experiencing fatigue. (Limit: You can only use this twice per day.)]

[Skill Option 2: Latent Power Surge - Drives the amplification of the circle to its far limit. You can triple your mana amplification for 30 seconds. However, after one use, you will be drained of all energy, and you will not be able to use the Asrahan Core Technique for a day. (Limit: You can only use this once per day.)]

[Skill Option 3: Power Saving Mode - Even in extreme exhaustion, you can use the Asrahan Core Technique, albeit weakly. The mana amplification rate is fixed at 25% at this state.]

[Required RP to level up: 500]

[Current RP: 46]

Wow. This is amazing. Lloyd opened his eyes wide. The amplification rate of the technique soared to 500%. As if to serve as evidence, a new ring was formed around his heart.

Ziiing! A third circle wrapped his heart around, and it began to resonate and rotate around the two circles. The result was marvelous.

Thud! Thuud! His heart started to pound with unprecedented strength. Blood coursed through his blood vessels at an abnormally high speed.

That wasn't all. His breathing felt different as well. One breath filled his muscles with strength, even when he was just breathing like he always did. It was like he was constantly taking in steroids through the air!

This is absolutely nuts. Is this the power of the triple circle? Lloyd's body felt the massive difference of a circle. *And my optional skills have improved as well.* The three skills in his options have comprehensively upgraded. The Energizer could last and happen twice more. The Latent Power Surge could last 10 more seconds. The amplification rate jumped five-fold. The same was true for the Power Saving Mode.

It has upped from 10% to 25%. It was a 15% bump he could utilize even when he was completely drained of energy. That difference would become the deciding factor between life and death during critical moments. That

wasn’t the end of his upgrades. There was something else that truly amazed him.

Ding Dong. The notification noise rang in his ears once more. Soon after, a completely unexpected message popped in front of him.

[A new skill option has been made available following your change in skill class.]

[Skill Option 4: Circle Shift - Allows you to adjust each of your circle’s rotation per minute (RPM) in six stages (1-6) and fixedly maintain it. This option will significantly help novices in using the mana blast.]

What is this... The message was a total surprise. A new opportunity he had never expected surfaced out of nowhere. Lloyd’s eyes filled with excitement for his future success as he read them.

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Chapter 75: Triple Circle (2)

What in the world is this... Lloyd opened his eyes wide. A new fourth optional skill? Circle shift? This was a reward Lloyd had never even dreamed of. The description of the skill seemed a bit familiar.

Rotation per minute? RPM? Gear from one to six? It looked like an explanation of an automatic transmission, and Lloyd thought he'd be able to adjust the rotation speed of the circle just like how he could change a car's gears.

Moreover, it's all separate. I can individually adjust the three circles.

Thump. Thump. His heart pounded as he read the skill description once again. He couldn't help himself. It was that amazing.

This is massive. Controlling the rotation power of the circles was difficult. Furthermore, what was more difficult was keeping a consistent, desired rotation speed for as long as he wanted.

To put it simply, rotating a mana circle around his heart was similar to twirling a large ring on his finger. Anyone could rotate the ring using one's finger, and the same went for controlling the rotation speed. However, keeping the rotation at a perfectly equal speed was a challenge. Almost an impossible challenge.

Of course. One can make it rotate at a similar speed, but perfect means keeping it exactly down to the millisecond without losing consistency. But now, with the circle shift made available, Lloyd was able to consistently adjust each of his three circles all at a different speed.

This optional skill is just out of this world. Lloyd gulped dryly. Until a while ago, he only had two circles. And so, he knew very well how tough it was to rotate several circles at differing speeds. Making that happen with two circles was more complex than twirling two rings on each of his hands at different speeds. It would be even harder now that he had three circles.

It’ll be like adding a ring on my ankle while keeping the two rings on my hands. And controlling each of them separately? That alone was beyond the scope of the skill. It almost bordered on a circus trick.

That was why Lloyd considered Javier a monster. He freely controlled the circles as soon as he created them. B*ut now, I can do it too.* He’d certainly be rougher and less refined than Javier. It would be impossible to adjust the power beyond the six stages.

Regardless, this is good enough. Controlling the gear through the circle shift and adjusting the rotation power using the gears...

Thanks to it, Lloyd managed to use the mana blast without going through any difficult training. *I must make the circles collide to use the mana blast.* But the circles held a repulsive force that pushed each other away. They were like two opposing poles of a magnet. And so, creating contact was extremely difficult.

Offsetting such repulsive power required high-speed rotation of the mana circles. But at the same time, the job required a more detailed and meticulous process than simply increasing the rotation speed.

I must have two circles rotate exactly at an accurate proportion. The rotation number was two to three, I think. Lloyd looked back on what had happened some time ago. The two to three rotation ratio... It was something Javier had off-handedly mentioned to him. He had said that it was the most ideal condition for collision. Lloyd remembered that Javier told him this, saying that he should refer to the ratio when he gets another circle. Just then…

“Grrrrrr!”

Something roared from behind. No, it came from above. Astonished, Lloyd lifted his head and looked up. He couldn’t see the night sky. Instead, he saw the mammoth body of the Gigatitan. This only meant one thing.

It’s here already?! Slam! Boooom! The Gigatitan banged the ground with its foreleg, crushing the spot where Ppodong stood just five seconds ago.

This is bad, really. Lloyd gulped dryly. He was out of time.

Grabbing onto Ppodong's ear, he yelled, "Ppodong!"

"P-Ppodong!"

Pant! Pant!

"Hey, you! You can run away without me, right?!"

"Ppodong!"

"Yes! A little more! I'm going to knock him out with one hit! So hold up until then! Okay?"

"P-Ppodong! Huff, huff!"

Ppodong nodded as he panted for air. Lloyd leaped from Ppodong's back. *Fwoosh!* His body floated in the air, and Ppodong's chubby back became far at once. It seemed his pace grew a bit faster because Lloyd's weight was off him. Just then, the pillar-like leg of the Gigatitan rushed from behind like greased lightning. *Fwoosh!*

Lloyd sucked in his breath. His body was still in the air as it was falling, and the leg of the monster charged fast at him. Lloyd braced himself for the impact.

Bam! He crashed against the leg of the monster like he was hit by a pillar. At that instant, Lloyd opened his arms wide and hugged its leg, catching on to the little protrusions of its shell. He was able to stay dangled without falling off, though his stomach churned a bit.

Urgh! The impact hit Lloyd right in the gut, and he could barely breathe from the intense pain. However, Lloyd clenched his teeth.

Goodness, it's not like I'm a star of an action movie or something! Lloyd stretched his hand out as he cursed his current situation. He grabbed on the protrusion above and started to crawl up as if he was rock climbing. Thankfully, he had enough stamina because of the triple circle.

Hundreds of yards stretched before him until he got up to its body. Making things worse, it continued to move nonstop. Even in such an unfavorable circumstance, Lloyd managed to quickly move like a cockroach crawling on top of a sink.

Faster! Quickly! He didn't have much time. The Gigatitan had almost caught up with Ppodong. *If I'm late, Ppodong and Javier will be done for.* And at last, Lloyd succeeded in going up the back shell of the monster. He rushed toward the direction of its head.

As he ran, he hastily practiced using the mana blast. *I don't have many chances. I must succeed with one try.* Basketball, soccer, dancing, swimming, and even walking required some practice to be proficient. It went without saying how much practice would be needed for the mana blast, which was one of the advanced skills in the Asrahan Core Technique.

The rotation ratio is two to three, right? Lloyd recalled Javier's advice and activated the Circle Shift he had just earned.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 4: Circle Shift has been activated.]

Since I'm just practicing, the gear should be set in one, two, and three. The gear set up was complete, and the three circles reacted instantly.

[The Alpha circle is set to gear 1. Fixed at RPM 1,000.]

[The Beta circle is set to gear 2. Fixed at RPM 2,000.]

[The Gamma circle is set to gear 3. Fixed at RPM 3,000.]

Ziiing...! The three circles rotated according to each of its powers.

Between them, the second and third circle showed an unusual reaction. He didn't have to push the two to collide. They automatically started to draw near.

Eh?! He jumped out of his skin and moved the first circle, hurriedly wrapping it around his heart, which was going at 1,000 RPM. The collision

took place afterward. *Kaboom!* The Beta circle and Gamma circle collided around the heart.

"…!"

This explosive pressure was something Lloyd had never experienced before. A destructive power rushed through him from the inside and hit his heart, which was wrapped with the Alpha circle.

"Argh!"

He wondered if this was what it felt like to have a seizure. Lloyd collapsed on the ground as he clasped his heart and stopped running. He quickly moved his two arms to carry the shovel hung around his back. Then, he dug into the ground and sent the destructive power to the shovel.

Crash! The mana blast shot out of the flat shovel, hitting the back shell of the Gigatitan. The impact sent Lloyd 150 feet in the air.

"Ack!"

He almost fell from its shell. Closely recovering the balance, he landed safely on the monster's back and clenched his shovel hard.

It's working. I succeeded. He successfully used the mana blast with his first attempt. No, it was more than just successful. *I didn't have to collide the circles by design. I just had to set the RPM according to the golden ratio, and the two collided on their own.*

It only meant one thing. He would be able to use the mana blast whenever he wanted.

Let's go! Lloyd jumped to his feet, feeling confident, and ran along its back. He neared the area near carapaces 11 and 12, where its weak spot would be. When he got there, it was time for him to do acrobatics.

"Huff! Huff!"

Lloyd crawled down to its side from the back of the Gigatitan and latched on to its carapace. *Come on, it's not like I'm going through military training right now!* The carapace was vast and wide, with a lot of thorns here and there. Lloyd grabbed one of them. And, dangling in the air, he grabbed the next one. He continued to move forward just like that.

Above him were the carapace and thorns. Hundreds of feet down him was the ground. *Don't look down.* He feared he'd get dizzy if he did so.

Fixing his gaze above, Lloyd dutifully moved from one thorn to another, and he approached the monster's fatal flaw like a mosquito in the summer secretly trying to latch onto a human body for blood. And at last, he arrived at the weak spot.

That's it. The connecting part between carapaces 11 and 12. Lloyd saw the hole in between. It was about 20 inches in diameter, and the dent was formed in the direction of the monster's head.

It's the place Javier hit with the maba blast. Lloyd tightened the grip around his shovel. He just needed to pierce into this area one more time. He collected his breath and fixed his shovel head exactly at the same angle as Javier did.

It needs to be done in one try. With such resolution in mind, he rotated his circles and set the speed using the Circle Shift. *Three, four, and six.*

Ziiing...! The circles reacted as soon as he activated the skill. The RPM was set at 3,000, 4,000, and 6,000 for each. Each of them went around this time much more fiercely.

Lloyd wrapped his heart with the Alpha circle with 3,000 RPM. *The last step is the collision.* Lloyd needed to immediately extract the power after the Beta circle with 4,000 RPM and Gamma circle with 6,000 RPM collided together.

He opened the path of the mana that travels to his right hand, ready to send the explosive power to the shovel. *Ziiing!* The Beta and Gamma circles resonated, and each narrowed in harmony. The collision would happen

soon. Lloyd waited for it to take place with his shovel aimed. It was just at that moment.

Grrrrrr! The Gigatitan let out a ferocious roar. It stopped charging ahead, letting go of Ppodong when it almost caught him. Instead, it drove into the ground with its club-like forearms. But before they hit the surface, it simply curled up the legs, and the rocks that crashed against the impact were sent catapulting in every direction.

The rocks flew up, each of them damaging and fatal. It was like the area between the carapaces 11 and 12 were bombarded with explosives. *Booom! Boom!*

Lloyd's eyes were on stalks as he got ready for the mana blast. It occurred to him that the monster might have noticed there was an enemy approaching its weak spot. It appeared so, indeed. That was the only reason why it would smash rocks in his direction.

Bam!

"…!"

Just then, a huge force knocked Lloyd's head. His head shook violently, and his upper torso bounced terribly. Blood spattered as his head was shoved to the side by the blow.

Was I hit? A sense of daze overcame him. He felt like time had frozen around him. Amid such circumstances, Lloyd's eyes moved, and they caught a rock that was falling to the ground. It was a little larger than a fist. It had blood on its side, which was smeared after it hit its head.

I can't fail... now... The mana blast. He wanted to succeed. He had boasted to Javier that he'd succeed. However, the strength in his grip loosened, and he let go of the protrusion he was grabbing with his left hand. His body then started to take a nosedive to the ground. A free fall.

No, I can't let that happen. Lloyd's eyes traveled up. Time still seemed to have slowed down. And in such slowness, the carapace of the Gigatitan was

slowly growing distant. There, he saw the closely bored hole that seemed strangely visible.

One more time. He just needed to stab it once. Not even twice, just once. Just once, and nothing more. *Let's stab it. Rotate the mana circles. Use the Circle Shift. Keep the ratio Javier taught me... two to three...*

Lloyd murmured unconsciously. The concussion was taking over his consciousness, and only one piece of memory was stuck in his head. Two to three. The mana circle rotation had to be kept at a ratio of two to three, and it had to be maintained when it collided.

Two to three... right before he lost consciousness... The Circle Shift was activated. It was the working of Lloyd's stubborn determination. There were no more detailed adjustments. Just two to three.

Reiterating the words over and over again in his head, Lloyd adjusted the gear out of his instinct. The Alpha circle was set to gear two, and the Beta and Gamma circles were set to gear three.

They rotated in a ferocious manner. *Ziiiiing!* With the Alpha circle at its center, the rest of them rotated. The three circles reverberated in 2:3 proportion. They drew near at a great speed as they reverberated. There wasn't a circle that protected the heart. The three of them collided altogether. At that moment, Lloyd, losing consciousness, stretched out his metal shovel the way his body remembered.

Slam! A massive destructive force discharged out of it with a loud noise. It dug into the Gigatitan's weak spot, ruining the muscle tissues and internal organs protected by its carapace. But the force continued to move. It penetrated. It charged. It smashed every bit of the organs that lay in its way. Then, it blasted and pierced the carapace.

Just like that, the force that was like a tsunami penetrated from the stomach to the back in one stroke. *Twack!* The marvelous blow was created out of Lloyd's determination and efforts. For the first time in history, a triple mana blast shot out.

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Chapter 76: A Miracle or an Opportunity? (1)

Crash! A massive force burst out like a powerful wave. It was the first triple circle mana blast in history. The force cut across everything that stood in its way as it rushed forward.

Grrr!! The Gigatitan let out a painful groan for the first time, and its monstrous body was penetrated at once.

The chitin and dense layers, which were hard on their own, had comprised the carapace shell from a molecular level. Then the honeycomb structure that was overlapped in three layers interwoven together one more time. So in short, its thickness and sturdiness was beyond extraordinary.

And that ridiculous structure was over three feet thick, so the monster's shell was a highly advanced natural bulletproof shield that was miles better than kevlar fibers or a composite armor. However, despite such defensive layers, it was useless against the triple circle mana blast.

Wham! The three-layered honeycomb structure cracked. The interwoven molecules melted.

The blazing heat of the mana blast forcibly penetrated the carapace shell that was three-foot thick. The tissue inside the sturdy and tough shell was relatively weak. The powerful storm of the force shoved its way, shattering and tearing every tissue there.

Tear! The first that got penetrated was the muscle tissues right inside the carapace. When the jellylike muscle tissues were exposed to high temperatures, the protein heated up, and the moisture within the tissues boiled away. It caused extensive damage to the surrounding tissues.

And yet, the blast's force was not diminished. It kept pushing forward, and this time, it hit the internal organs. *Crack!* The dorsal nerve cord that ran along its lower body like a spine was pierced through. It snapped, and the huge nerve tissue let out a fatal cry.

The same thing took place with the tissues behind it. The coiled heart just above the dorsal nerve cord was penetrated, as well as its lungs which provided oxygen to its vast body. A portion of the kidney that was bigger than a house and its hormone glands, the muscle tissues on its back, and finally, the three-foot thick sturdy back shell was smashed to pieces. They were melted and ripped apart. They were shattered and penetrated.

Kaboom! The violent and rough force of fire burst through the back of the monster. Shredded strands and pieces of internal organs spurted out in all directions like fireworks as the mana blast continued to charge forward.

Then, they fell down like rain. Lloyd rained down with them. He was sinking into a state of total unconsciousness as he fell.

I'm tired... The distance between the carapace and the ground was about 200 yards, and Lloyd plummeted to the ground like a kite with a cut tail. He could neither balance himself nor brace for an impact. No, he didn't have the mind to. Everything felt numb in his head. It all felt like a dream. Lloyd's looked straight ahead with a vague gaze. The bottom of the coastal cliff clogged up with gray rocks came fast into his view.

'…….'

He wouldn't be safe if his body continued to plummet down. That was his last thought before Lloyd passed out. His body, on the other hand, continued to fall. But right before he hit the ground, Lloyd's body became buried under fluffy hair.

"Ppodong!"

Plop! Ppodong, who zoomed to his side just in time, caught Lloyd with his fluffy and chubby back. The thick and soft bed of hair allowed Lloyd to remain uninjured, and he was saved from being bounced off to the ground. But Ppodong couldn't smile in satisfaction for his feat or be relieved for catching Lloyd. It wasn't the time to laugh or be relieved.

"Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!"

Pant! Pant! Instead of being relieved, Ppodong strove to run faster, his breath getting shorter as he ran. Just then, a giant shadow flooded behind Ppodong. *Grrrr...!*

Bam! Then, Ppodong heard a loud bang along with a roar near the rocks he had passed by earlier. More rocks smashed to pieces, and the blaring noise of breaking rocks mingled with the death throes of the dying monster.

Grrrrrrrrrr! It was the noise the Gigatitan made as it violently moved. The connecting ligament between carapaces 11 and 12 held a weak spot, and a large hole was bored through it. A part of the dorsal nerve cord was snapped, and the heart and respiratory organs burst had out.

The critical hit would inevitably kill the monster. Despite that, the monster stubbornly struggled, and with an amazing show of stamina, life, and savageness, it delayed its inescapable death by a few seconds. Thus, it was going berserk, squeezing out every strength left in it as death closed in on it. Madness swept over the monster. It rushed to destroy anything in its sight. The rocks in the coastal cliff and Ppodong rushing ahead of it were all objects to be destroyed.

“Grrrrr!!”

Slam! Crash! The club-like forearms doggedly rained down, and Ppodong hurried all the more. His breathing became short, and his legs gave way. And yet, he continued to run.

He jumped over rocks and moved on, struggling to get as away from the Gigatitan as much as possible. But the monster’s determination was a bit stronger than his speed. *Crash!*

“Ppo...?”

Its forearm propelled down, blocking the front of Ppodong. Ppodong stopped dead in his tracks in surprise and hurriedly tried slip out through the left side. However, his attempt was blocked again.

Crash! The other forearm blocked his escape route. Ppodong's round eyes swelled with frustration.

"Ppodong?"

There was no way out. His right and rear were blocked with a giant rock. Certainly, Ppodong could climb up the rock, but he wondered if the Gigatitan would sit and wait while he struggled to climb up the rock. The answer was no. There was no way out. Climbing over the rock would get him caught. Therefore, Ppodong thought there was only one method left in him.

"Ppodong! Ppo-do-dong! Hmphh!!"

He glared at the Gigatitan fiercely, revealing his front teeth and growling aloud. The monster's upper torso fell down in the direction of Ppodong. Its wide-opened mouth rushed to his side, and it plunged right onto the ground.

Boooom!

"……!"

Ppodong's buttock flinched hard. A little later, this loyal and chubby summon creature was able to witness a surprising spectacle. *Thud... Thud...* Amid the splattering of rock powder and dust, Ppodong saw an outline of the giant monster.

But the giant body was not moving. It was neither moving nor breathing. That only meant one thing.

"Ppodong?"

The monster's breathing had stopped. Ppodong's eyes widened as he realized that it was dead. But despite the fact that he was alive and safe, he neither congratulated nor rejoiced in being alive.

Instead, he ran on. He left the monster and ran ahead without halting for a second. His heart was almost bursting with exhaustion, but he went on. He did so for Lloyd on his back.

“Ppodong! Ppo-do-dong!”

Lloyd was on his back, and his heartbeat was very faint. His breaths were extremely faint. There was no time to waste. He had to save his owner.

“Ppo-do-dong!”

Pant! Pant!

“Ppodong!”

Just a little more. Just endure a little longer. Ppodong ran as if he was encouraging both himself and Lloyd. He was heading toward the city district of Cremo, where the chaos had died down. And behind him was the dead body of the giant monster that shone under the moonlight. The disastrous night was drawing to a close.

♣

Six days later. The citizens in the city were starting to recover from the shock of the incident following the death of the monster.

Everyone became one in clearing the broken rocks and restoring the crumbled walls. The injured ones received appropriate treatment in time, and those who lost their homes got help from their neighbors.

But no one forgot what happened that night. They couldn’t forget about it. Everyone could still see a giant silhouette lurking on the ground, immobile and dead, whenever they turned their heads as they cleared the rocks, built walls, or nursed others. The carcass of the Gigatitan. It was left at the coastal cliff as if it was sleeping. People recounted the night of the disaster as they looked at the giant carcass.

At the same time, they were relieved. The disaster was uncalled for, and yet not a single one died despite the frenzied chaos.

“It was a miracle. I never expected that someone come to my rescue this fast when I was flailing my arms in the water.”

A middle-aged woman was getting treated in the infirmary as she spoke.

“It was like thunder. The noise. The boat fluctuated violently, and I felt my whole body turn upside down at that moment. The next thing I know is that I was in the cold water, struggling to swim. Yes. The moment the monster hit the boat, I was sent flying away into the water,” she continued to speak.

“So? How did you get out of the sea?” asked a volunteer.

The other volunteers pricked up their ears. The middle-aged woman smiled faintly and said, “that man held out his hand.”

“That man?”

“I do not know his name. He is the one that summoned the large creature at the plaza last month.”

“Oh, that man. I know him. The snake-like creature belched out a large amount of gas into a large diaper.”

“Yes, him. He didn’t hesitate to come down and help me get out of the water. I wasn’t the only one. He saved an old man who was losing consciousness and sinking and a struggling child beside him. The man saved them all.”

“Woah...”

The volunteers let out a sound of adoration at her story. Another talk was taking place at the central plaza beside the infirmary.

“Hey, did you hear?”

“Hear what?”

“The story about the young man.”

“What nonsense are you talking about? Give me some context.”

“Oh, the young man, you know. The one who boasted around that he’s going to construct something near the shore.”

“Oh! That fellow.”

They were at the plaza that was partly destroyed by the statue that fell from the sky. The workers were chatting as they repaired the place.

“What about the young man?”

“I heard that it was him who put out the fire.”

“Fire? How?”

“He called a summon partner. I heard the chubby creature splashed water over the fire or something.”

“That was how he did it?”

“Yeah. And thanks to him, the fire was put out.”

“Haha, really? Is that possible?”

“The story must be going around because it is possible. There are many witnesses.”

“Is that so?”

Some workers had their ears to the ground as they worked while some shared the stories they’d heard with a glimmer in their eyes. However, the story wasn’t being spread around just in infirmaries and plazas.

“I saw it myself. It is all true.”

“True? Be more specific. Are you saying that Lloyd Frontera bore a large hole into the Gigatitan’s huge body?”

“Yes, he did.”

The conversation was taking place in the meeting room of Count Cremo's study. A follow-up investigation was underway, which was led by an investigative committee.

The commander of post 23, who appeared before the body as a reference, nodded his head. "If you do not mind, may I walk you through what I saw one by one?" he asked.

"Yes, please do."

"Thank you."

The commander collected his breath and continued to speak.

"To be completely honest, I resolved to die that night. The post was smashed, and the Gigatitan had already made inroads to the land. So, I decided to take action."

"What action?" one of the committee members asked.

"I blew up the gunpowder in the post."

"Gunpowder?"

"Yes, I meant to attack the Gigatitan but failed."

"Did it not get hit?"

"No, it wasn't hurt at all. I was on the brink of death, and that man showed up to save me."

"Lloyd Frontera did?"

"Yes, he did." The commander nodded.

His gaze then traveled the people present in the room, from the count to the other members of the committee. Putting more force in his voice, he said, "He saved my life, and not only that, he evacuated me to a safe place and fought head-on."

“Do you mean the Gigatitan?”

“Yes. Technically speaking, the silver-haired knight fought first, and he came later to help.”

The commander of post 23 continued to explain. He shared the story of Javier fighting against the Gigatitan. And how Lloyd drew the monster's attention with the repaired mermaid statue. How Javier passed out, and Lloyd ran and fought back. And lastly, he shared the mysterious explosion that penetrated the Gigatitan’s body.

While the story was being revealed, the count and every committee member clenched their fists, gulped drily, and let out intermittent moans and made sounds of adoration. The story was too impressive to believe right away, but it was impossible to distrust it. That was because of the smoking gun. The huge hole drove into the Gigatitan’s body.

The count asked, “Did you get to take a closer look at how Lloyd Frontera created that hole in its body?”

“No, he was so far away from me, and it was dark. I couldn’t get a closer look at how it was done. However, it was very...”

“Very?”

“It looked like he was shooting a powerful cannon.”

“A cannon?” repeated the count.

“Yes.”

“Hmm, a cannon...”

The count furrowed his brows. None of the cannons he owned managed to penetrate the monster’s shell. And yet, Lloyd had looked like he was shooting a cannon?

“Could it be that he secretly used powerful magic?” the count speculated.

“I have a feeling that he did,” the commander seconded.

“I see. Thank you for sharing the story. Good job. You may go now.”

“Yes, Your Excellency. Thank you,” he said before he went out.

The members of the committee, now left to themselves, chatted with one another. Meanwhile, the count quietly closed his eyes.

Whew... I hope he wakes up soon. The count thought about Lloyd. The very young man who came from the Frontera fiefdom that sat in the corner of the east. The count counted the handful of accomplishments that the young man achieved overnight.

If it weren’t for him, I’d have died that night too. He was telling the truth. It must have been some seconds before the Gigatitan emerged and crushed the statue. At that moment, Lloyd had sliced the anchor ropes of the boats. It was thanks to his actions that the boat the count was on narrowly managed to avoid Gigatitan’s ambush.

There was more. They were able to rescue a countless number of people in the sea because they had an intact sailboat. *And not only that, he extinguished the fire that spread in the city district and killed the monster with his hands. I can’t count the amount of debt this city's people and I owe him for this.* A sense of gratitude flooded his heart. *Please, wake up, dear friend.* The count sincerely wished that. Lloyd was the reason that miraculously no one had died in this incident, and the count wished that a miracle would fall on him as well.

After the night of the disaster, Lloyd’s heart stopped. It didn’t beat again. But he wasn’t dead. He was still breathing. His heart stopped, but his breathing continued. This lasted for the past six days.

It was a mystery no one had ever heard of or seen before. As such, the count was absolutely clueless. No, it wasn’t just him. Everyone in the city was left in the dark. Lloyd’s heart, which seemed to have stopped from the impact of the mana blast, was going through something strange, unprecedented, and miraculous.

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Chapter 77: A Miracle or an Opportunity? (2)

“I have never seen anything like this before,” said the physician as he gazed up.

There was an evident look of confusion on his face.

“His heart is clearly not beating. It’s only natural for him to die. No, he should have been dead already. But he’s alive. He’s even breathing...”

“Very perfectly, yes?” said the count.

“Yes,” replied the physician.

Lloyd was on the bed, and the physician’s gaze toward him was beyond dismay. It was chaos. It made sense. After all, it only made sense for a person whose heart stopped to die. That was the law of nature. But right in front of the physician was an exception.

At first, he wondered if he was looking at an undead creature. He thought the man was a freshly made zombie. But that wasn’t the case. This patient was well and alive! The count smiled in a wry way.

“Could you please explain some more?”

“Oh, yes, Your Excellency.”

The physician wiped his half-balded head with a handkerchief. Then, he continued to explain, “As you are aware, the heart is an organ that provides blood all over the body. Therefore, there is no pulse when the heart stops. Dead. But this patient is...”

“What is it?”

The count asked.

“His pulse is still there, even when his heart has stopped.”

The physician’s words went on.

“That’s not just it. He’s even breathing. His body has a slight fever, but overall, his body temperature is just normal. So that makes me wonder all the more. Tell me, Your Excellency, has this patient received some sort of magic treatment?”

The count shook his head as he replied, “No, he has never received such a thing.”

Since the Gigatitan wreaked disastrous havoc on the city that night, Lloyd wasn’t able to receive proper treatment after losing consciousness. Perhaps, the more accurate words would be that there was no method to cure him.

After all, no one dared to even try. Lloyd’s current state certainly was a mystery. His heart wasn’t beating. However, his pulse was all right and breathing was even as well. Each time the count brought in physicians, they were flustered, terrified, and shocked after assessing Lloyd. The same thing was happening today.

“Actually, I called other physicians before you came,” confessed the count. “You’re the 11th one to see him.”

“…….”

“Everyone showed the same reaction as you did. No one could find a cure since they couldn’t find the cause. Is that the same with you?” asked the count.

“I...”

“You can be frank with me. This is such a mysterious case, so no one is going to question your capacity.”

“I am sorry.”

“It is as expected, I see.”

“Yes, I have never seen a patient like this before...”

“It’s all right. It must not have been easy to travel all the way here. Thank you for visiting. Go now. The butler will take care of your compensation and reward,” said the count.

“Yes. Please excuse me.”

With that, the 11th physician left the place without any fruit. The count’s face darkened.

No one has found a way to wake him up. Lloyd Frontera was lying on the sick bed. Count Cremo didn’t want to lose him. The night of the disaster. The count wanted to save Lloyd the more he thought back about his debt to his unconscious friend.

Countless people are indebted to this young man. I, too, am indebted to him. If it weren’t for him, I wonder if I’d be fine as I am now.

He wouldn’t have been fine had it not for Lloyd’s determination. The sailboat he was on would have been attacked by the Gigatitan. He would have lost his life along with his only daughter.

The mere thought of it was awful. Shaking off the goosebumps, the count moved his gaze as and asked, “are you not tired?”

“I am fine, Your Excellency.”

The count was gazing at the corner of the ward. There, the wordless silver-haired knight faintly shook his head.

The count’s smile turned more bitter.

“I know that you’ve not healed completely yet.”

“I have enough strength to protect Master Lloyd.”

“How amazing.”

“You exaggerate.”

In actuality, Javier was wearing a splint on his left arm. He wasn't fully healed from the injury the Gigatitan gave him that night with its forearm.

"I am perfectly fine as long as I can use my right arm."

"But, you see, I think you have been staying up four straight days."

"Insomnia is keeping me awake every night," replied Javier.

"Is it the sword-master syndrome?"

"Yes, it looks like it," Javier replied as he nodded.

At first, he had no idea. But thanks to Lloyd, Javier learned somewhat about insomnia that he was having now.

"You are experiencing the syndrome at such a young age. How amazing."

"It is all because of my lord's generosity."

"Do you mean Baron Frontera?"

"Yes," said Javier.

"I envy him."

"Should you want it, I can relay the message to my lord."

"No, don't."

The count waved his hands.

"What a close-minded fellow you are. The baron would be terrified if you told him that. I am not the kind of person who covets someone's aid. Never do I wish to be misunderstood that way. But..."

The count paused, his eyes meaningfully glimmering.

"However this incident gets concluded, it looks like you will be a bit busy."

“I’m not sure what you mean.”

“His Majesty.”

The count continued to talk.

“I am bounded by the duty to report this matter to His Majesty. That is because all the lands of this kingdom are under His grace. And so, I cannot omit the story of your people.”

“……”

Javier faintly nodded. It was obvious. Javier had prevented the Gigatitan from getting into the city. And Lloyd finished the monster after. That was a fact they could never hide, even if they tried.

“His Majesty will show great interest in you. Anyway, what we can hope for right now is for him to wake up without any problems. His Majesty wouldn’t want such a talent to never open his eyes again.”

“The feeling is mutual,” agreed Javier.

“Anyway, I have been ranting. I shall go now. I’ll come here again at this time tomorrow with another physician.”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“If you’re tired, have someone tell me. My knights can protect him just as well.”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“Whew, how rigid you are.”

“Thank you.”

That got the count to burst into a fit of laughter. He shot a worried glance at Lloyd the last time before he left. Now, only Lloyd and Javier were left.

“Whew...”

Javier finally let out a sigh, which he had been suppressing. Then, he threw a confused gaze toward the bed. *Are you okay, Master Lloyd?* Lloyd was lying on the sickbed as if he was sleeping. Javier’s blue eyes grew dismayed as they watched him.

Just then, he recalled the event of the previous day. It must have been after the tenth physician visited. Like the others before him, he wasn’t able to figure out what was going on with Lloyd. The mere sight of it frustrated Javier. And so, when he was left alone with Lloyd, Javier inspected Lloyd’s state in secret. Unlike the physicians, he resorted to using his own mana method. What he found out from it completely shocked him.

He has reached the triple circle stage. Javier could feel it as soon as he injected the mana. There were three circles wrapped around his heart. Lloyd had always remained at the double circle stage, but he had created another circle after passing out from fighting the Gigatitan.

There was something more that was shocking. *The three circles are spinning at lightning speed.* It was an unimaginable speed. The rotation speed was near the limit of the Asrahan Core Technique. Thanks to it, a powerful mana had completely enveloped Lloyd’s heart.

As such, Javier couldn’t look into the circle. He could neither look how his heart was. There was no way for Javier to guess what was going on in there. His confusion didn’t end there.

The carcass of the Gigatitan I’d seen two days ago was... worse. Javier could clearly recall the gigantic carcass that had fallen off the coastal cliff. He had taken part of the investigation to examine the monster, so he got a vivid view of the fatal wound in its body. There was a giant hole in the weak spot of the monster, the area between carapaces 11 and 12, which Lloyd had mentioned.

Javier knew right away as soon as he saw it. It was the mark of the mana blast. So, he was even more confused. *The size and power of that mana blast was... too different from what I’m familiar with.* The size was

alarming. The power was maddening. A torch and a candle. A cannon and a marble. That was how much of a difference there was between his mana blast and what he saw. The more he observed it, the more awe he felt. Whatever the case was, one thing was for sure. That out-of-this-world mana blast had been used by Lloyd.

How in the world... Javier thought that there was some kind of connection between that massively powerful mana blast and Lloyd's current state. But there was no way for him to figure out the details.

What on earth did you do on that day, Master Lloyd? Javier tossed a gaze that was filled with deep curiosity and worry. But Lloyd didn't answer from the sick bed. The only response was his soft breathing.

Javier continued to watch over Lloyd, and the winter sunlight streaming into the tranquil ward curved in silence. But of course, Javier was absolutely in the dark about something. He had zero idea that an unprecedented miracle was starting to take place inside of Lloyd as he was looking at his young master.

♣

Thump. Thump. Lloyd's heart pounded. No, it was the mana that did. His heart had stopped. It was obvious.

A few days earlier, his heart had received a great shock. It was exposed to the blow of the mana blast without any circle to protect it. What was worse was that it wasn't an ordinary mama blast. It was the product of three circles. And the fierce collision and its power struck Lloyd's heart without any protection.

If it was Javier or any other knight, the blow would have killed him in an instant. But Lloyd was different. He didn't die. His heart didn't burst. The manaheart in his heart didn't explode. The reason was simple. He had no manaheart.

Thump... Thump... Lloyd had never managed to make a manaheart. That was also the case back when he started to prepare for the duel against Sir

Neumann. He had no manaheart. To be accurate, he had no time to create a manaheart. In the first place, it wasn't easy to make. The process demanded a great amount of time and effort. Even a rare genius needed at least six months and protege would take at least two years to create one. Thus, it was obvious what the case would be for ordinary people. At best, they would need five years, and a slow person could need more than ten years.

Obviously, Lloyd wasn't a genius or a protege. He was a person who learned the Asrahan Core Technique just to fight Sir Neumann. And once he learned it, he thought that was enough. There was no need to be hung up on developing a manaheart. That was excessive. As such, Lloyd didn’t have a manaheart.

Unlike the flashy sides of the mana circles wrapped around his heart, the inside of his heart was like any other one. That was what saved him. It had saved his life from the force of the mana circles.

Thud! Thud! In the first place, a manaheart inside a human body wasn’t natural. It was the product of purposeful training. People shoved an unnaturally large amount of mana into their hearts to exert more force and power. That was the essence and identity of the manaheart.

But Lloyd didn’t have that. In other words, from the mana perspective, Lloyd’s heart was almost an empty space. There was no manaheart to burst. There was nothing. The blow of the mana blast worked instead to fill up that empty space, and the explosive power filled and coagulated. And once it got coagulated, it created the nucleus, the core of the special skill. Afterward, the mana storm was recomposed with the nucleus at its center, and it landed inside the heart.

Carefully, Slowly, but firmly. *Thump...! Thump!* Inside the fast-spinning circles, a completely new manaheart was coming into existence.

♣

A few days passed. Meanwhile, Cremo, the city of commerce, was cleaned up. Everyone worked hard to move on from the disaster, and the central plaza was restored. The broken buildings and bell tower were repaired,

although haphazardly. The destroyed post 23 was stacked up again, and most of the injured people had got back on their feet.

Various rumors spread throughout the day. One of the rumors said that there was someone who saved people from drowning after the sailboats crashed and sunk because of the Gigatitan. Another said that a man put out the spreading fire near the plaza by using his summon partner. Additionally, there was a rumor about one man heroically fighting against the monster. There was also word about how the man who killed the Gigatitan was currently in a coma.

Just like that, many rumors spread around, each story and word piecing together like a puzzle. The truth was naturally revealed little by little. The man, who saved people from drowning in the sea, had also put out the fire. The same man, who put out the fire, had also killed the Gigatitan. And now, after killing the monster, the man was in a coma on the sick bed.

At last, everyone became enlightened. Lloyd Frontera. That was his work. Everyone was safe, thanks to him. Since that day, one by one, people started to gather at the plaza. It was for one reason. They all had one wish.

“Are you asking why we’re gathered here on such a cold day? It’s obvious. We wish for Lloyd Frontera, the man who saved us, to wake up alive.”

That was why they had gathered here. The biting cold of the winter couldn’t dampen their spirit. The wish of the people for Lloyd’s recovery was bigger and hotter than the icy wind. They prayed and sang with their hearts together as one. They thought that was the way to repay their debt to Lloyd, who had given his life for the city.

Ten days passed. The last day of the year rolled around. The winter was especially icy that day. And just as everyone wished, Lloyd opened his eyes.

[You have saved a lot of people from disaster with your sacrifice and valor, setting an example. The citizens of Cremo, the city of commerce, are deeply moved by your sacred action.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a massive bonus.]

[To read more about the bonus, please select “Here.”]

[You have survived the damage from the triple circle mana blast. You have acquired a unique manaheart through this special experience.]

[Manaheart skill has been upgraded.]

[To read more about the upgrade, please select “Here.”]

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Chapter 78: A Miracle or an Opportunity? (3)

Where am I? And what am I doing here on this unfamiliar bed?

"..."

Lloyd blinked several times. He wondered how long he had been asleep. His eyes felt heavy, and his neck and back ached as well. Lloyd thought to himself, *I wish I possessed a new body. Seriously, I wish I was transmigrated into another person with a silver spoon whose parents are loaded. Seriously.*

Of course, his current situation was much different. That was something Lloyd knew very well. A cascade of messages floated in front of him the moment he opened his eyes. As he read them through, Lloyd vaguely formed an idea of what had happened to him.

[You have saved a number of people from disaster with your sacrifice and valor, setting an example. The citizens of Cremo, the city of commerce, are deeply moved by your selfless action.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 1,000 RP.]

[Current RP: 1,046]

I did what? Sacrifice, valor, set an example? Saved a bunch of people from a disaster? Haha. Lloyd gave a laugh as he looked at the message in front of his eyes. Setting an example? Sacrifice and valor? No, thank you.

Even if people asked for them, he'd have flatly rejected them. And yet, here he was, reading the message that he had done those deeds. But that wasn't the end of the messages. There were more.

[The people of the city of commerce are praising you as the “Guardian of Cremo.”]

[Your steadfast valor, determination, and sacrificial spirit tugged at the heartstrings of many.]

[This is a commerce city. Countless merchants and visitors will encounter your accomplishment from the citizens here, and they will be amazed.]

[The story of your heroic feat will be spread by the merchants and will reach several parts of the kingdom.]

[Many artists inspired by your heroic feat will create various art pieces.]

[For a while, songs, plays, and art pieces of your accomplishment will become a trend.]

[You have become a national star.]

[Your name and accomplishment will, albeit a line, be written in the history of the kingdom.]

[For the increase in social reputation, you have been awarded bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 500 RP.]

[Current RP: 1,546]

Wow. Looks like I’ve struck gold. The flood of messages continued without a break, and Lloyd was almost lost in it. At the same time, Lloyd realized one thing. *I vanquished the Gigatitan. I did.*

The monster was too ferocious to fight against. There seemed to be no way of killing it. So, he had tried to hide somewhere while it wreaked havoc on the city. And yet, it was Lloyd himself who finished the Gigatitan.

It felt unreal. But it looked like it was true. Just then, the image he saw before losing consciousness came to his mind. The gigatitan. Its weak spot. Getting ready to use the mana blast. And the barrage of rocks that flew out of nowhere.

And I got knocked in the head. The sensation still felt raw. He vaguely remembered something hit him in the head with a thud. And the whole world suddenly moved in slow motion. It was the process of fainting. And amid that he...

I used the mana blast in the most foolish way possible. Two to three. That was the ideal rotation proportion of the mana circle when using the mana blast. He had obsessively repeated the ratio in his head even while he was passing out. And so, he did something utterly irrational.

I didn't protect my heart. He had used the circle needed to protect his heart in the mana blast. And the three circles collided altogether. The overpowering shock shook his body, and that impact was the last thing he remembered.

And yet, I am alive. He didn't die. In fact, Lloyd was perfectly fine. His heart pounded with vigor. No, it felt more vitalized than before.

However, Lloyd didn't panic or become dazed. Instead, he observed the messages that had been floating since a while ago. And they were kindly walking him through what was happening now.

My manaheart skill has developed? Lloyd knit his eyebrows. A manaheart. He didn't have one yet, and he never thought he would even in the future.

The required training is much too tiring and tedious. Even the fastest learners take at least five years. That's why I'd decided to do away with the manaheart training. t was true. The manaheart required intense and consistent daily training. Thus, he gave up on the idea. He had decided it would be more profitable for him to do another construction project rather than spend time training.

Plus, I had the mana circles that could replace the manaheart. That granted him to have about an equal amount of strength to the knights. Beside him was Javier. Lloyd fully trusted Javier's swordsmanship, and he was confident that he wouldn't get stabbed to death. He decided that was more than enough and settled on the decision.

But I guess I have a manaheart now. He felt like he had received a surprise gift. He closely looked at the skill descriptions like he was opening a gift box.

Ding Dong.

[Opening the skill information.]

[Skill Name: Manaheart.]

[Stage: Mana User Lv. 1]

[You can artificially save highly dense mana in your heart. The stored mana can be used freely at any time. This will greatly help your physical ability, and your storage and efficiency will increase the more you level up.]

[Physical ability improvement rate: 150%]

[Required RP to level up: 50]

[Current RP: 1,546]

Dang. This is nuts. This is absolutely nuts. Lloyd clicked his tongue. He truly had a real manaheart. Deep down, he always wanted to create one but gave up because it required too much time and effort. However, he had gained one through unlocking a skill.

His heartbeat felt a bit different. *Thump! Thump!*

Each time his heart pumped, Lloyd sensed a lump of mana the size of a plum gathered in it. However, its capacity was closer to a straight-four sedan engine despite its size. Strength overflowed his heart, like he had

built an engine in his heart. Plus, the energy felt natural like it was part of his body. He felt like he could send it to his arms and legs if he chose to.

I really became a mana user. Using mana was the yardstick that distinguished someone from ordinary people. So, what would happen if such power was linked with the triple circle? Lloyd thought he would be able to exert more power than most mid-level sword experts. If he was lucky, he might be able to narrowly match with a high-level sword expert.

However, that wasn't all of the gifts he received. The real deal followed soon after.

Ding Dong.

[Your manaheart was born, not as a result of regular training but from the impact of the mana blast.]

[As such, your manaheart has been given unique capabilities.]

[A new skill option has been opened.]

[Skill Option 1: Shock Neutralizer - Neutralizes any impact from a mana blast without additional protection. Therefore, your manaheart does not get any damage from the mana blast. This optional skill will greatly help you overcome the limitations of having one circle protect your heart when you need to use the mana blast.]

Shut up. His eyes widened in wonder as he read them. He even had an option that made him gulp by reflex. His mind started ticking.

So, let me just get this straight. Now that I have obtained the manaheart as a skill, I can invest in RP to become a high-level sword expert or higher. I can also unlock more optional skill in the meantime. Plus, now, I'm equipped with a fantabulous optional skill that protects me from the impact of the mana blast. In short, he had hit the jackpot. No, he had hit the biggest jackpot ever.

This meant that he didn’t have to protect his heart when using the mana blast. He would be able to use the triple circle collision, which he used against the Gigatitan before passing out, anytime he pleased.

It was the triple-collision mana blast that killed the Gigatitan, I suppose. Does this mean that the power of the blast will increase exponentially as the number of collisions go up? If that’s the case, then my blast is going to exponentially get more powerful... It was just when Lloyd was engrossed in his calculation. A familiar face slipped in between the floating messages, and he talked to Lloyd.

“Are you alive by any chance.”

“...”

It was Javier. He tossed the question to Lloyd, with his ever-the-same indifferent gaze and stoic face and in his usual chilly voice.

“Any plans on falling back into a coma again?”

“Do you really want that to happen to me again...?”

“Hmm, to be honest...”

Javier tilted his head to one side, thinking.

“I think I do.”

“...”

“I lived a very comfortable life when you were out.”

“Comfortable?”

“Yes.”

Javier continued to respond in an unconcerned manner.

“I only had to stay beside you while you were asleep. I didn’t have to split rocks or blast the ground. I didn’t have to drive stakes into the ground with a hammer. There was also no need to do any dreadful shoveling anymore.”

“Haa. Looks like you’ve been having the time of your life.”

“That is perfectly correct.”

“That’s why you’re now upset that I’m awake, eh?”

“Yes.”

“Wow. You don’t even try to deny it.”

“When a leader starts excessively working, it’s natural that those that work under him get tired too.”

“So, what is the meaning of your right hand that’s raised in the air?”

“...”

“You’re not going to knock me unconscious with it, are you? Like you’re going to smack me to sleep or anything.”

“...”

“Look at you sneakily opening up your fist after my words.”

“That is ridiculous. I would never dare to.”

Javier stretched his hand and propped Lloyd’s nape and back firmly. Then, he slowly helped Lloyd sit up. Lloyd had lied down for too long.

“Argh.”

Lloyd felt a bit dizzy, but he wasn’t in a bad mood. He felt even better when he saw the smile on Javier’s face, which betrayed his playful words.

“I am relieved, Master Lloyd.”

“Indeed. It’s a relief. I can torture you again.”

“Yes, it is. I am relieved that your years of being single can be extended.”

“Yeah, it really is. I think I can tell the baron about how you are trying to walk all over me.”

“Is it possible you’re being serious?”

“It depends on how you behave.”

“That means you won’t do it.”

“Dang. Don’t be so confident.”

“Am I wrong?”

“You better wish that you’re right. You should pray every night from now on.”

Lloyd then laughed out loud. It was sincere, and he was relieved. He and Javier were safe.

Lloyd grinned, thinking that it truly was a relief. This prompted Javier to be deadpan and put on a straight face. And that made Lloyd laugh again.

That was when everything finally felt real. Everything was over. It was now time to reap the awards of his hard work.

♣

The rewards were more enduring, out-of-this-world, and comprehensive than he expected. The news of his recovery brought a queue of visitors. The first person that sprinted to his ward was no other than Count Cremo.

“Are you interested in being my son-in-law?”

“Excuse me...?”

The count, the moment he stepped into the ward, asked if Lloyd wanted to get married to his daughter. And, of course, he had a huge bouquet of flowers that wished Lloyd a fast recovery.

“I’m not sure what you mean.”

“Of course you do. Should I repeat myself?” asked the count.

“...”

“Be my son-in-law.”

“...”

Lloyd clamped his mouth shut. At first, he wondered if the man wasn’t in his right mind. But his gaze and voice weren’t playful. Just one nod. That was enough for the count to bring his only daughter and rush them into the wedding ceremony. So Lloyd flatly shook his head.

“Please forgive me.”

“Why is that?”

“I am indeed grateful for your good will and offer, but...” Lloyd trailed off.

“But?”

“I don’t think I can handle it.”

It was the truth. Getting married so suddenly? And with the only daughter of the count? On the outside, it could come across as an amazing opportunity. But the reality would be different, Lloyd thought to himself.

Getting married at this point in time? It would be a nightmare. I’d have to spend money to keep up to their noble stature, and the wedding ceremony is going to cost me money, too. And if I have a child, the diaper, the milk, the education, all of it will cost me another sum. I won’t be able to pay off the barony’s debt then.

Certainly, the count could pay the debt for him. But it would never be for free. He'd be just making a new form of intangible debt to the count. Lloyd didn't want his hands to get tied that much to the count. All he wanted in life was to clear the debt from the loan sharks and goof around and enjoy life in freedom. Live modestly in peace and without anything lacking. Just live a simple life. That's all he wanted. So, tying the knot with a count's daughter and such nobility wasn't much of a noble decision. Lloyd hung his head down again.

"I am sorry, Your Excellency."

"Tsk. Is that so?"

"Yes, but I appreciate your kind words."

"You should appreciate both my words and proposal."

"I am really sorry, Your Excellency."

"Well, then. There's nothing I can do."

Count Cremo licked his lips in regret. After that, quite a lot of people visited him. A business family in the city. A tycoon in the shipbuilding industry. An opulent moneybag who made riches by offering private guard service. All of them were influential people in the city, and they all asked the same question during their visits.

"Do you want to become a member of my family?"

The marriage proposals disguised as a hospital visit, continued. Lloyd shook his head each time. He had already said no to the count. There was no reason for him to accept their suggestion for marriage. But instead of a flat rejection, he did so with courtesy, making sure that he still maintained good relationship with them.

"Yikes. It's another marriage proposal this time too. I feel like I've become a hot local celebrity."

It surprised Lloyd how everyone who visited him had the same goal in mind. However, it only meant that his reputation had gone up that much. It also meant that he was now the most sought after bachelor across the whole city. The thought elated him as this was something that he could never even dream of happening to him back in Korea. Javier, who was tending to Lloyd in the ward, let out a laugh.

“A celebrity? Congratulations.”

“Hmm... Why do I have this feeling that you’re mocking me?”

“Absolutely not.”

“No?”

“Yes.”

“Then, how do you explain that?” asked Lloyd.

“Excuse me?”

“The bundle of letters in your hand.”

“Oh,” Javier said as he looked down at his hand.

“Could it be...”

“Yes, it is.”

“Seriously?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Those are the love letters you received while I was passed out?”

“Yes.”

“...”

“Do you want me to count how many?” asked Javier.

“No, don’t do it.”

“Five... Seven... Eleven... Twenty...”

“I said don’t count.”

“39 in total.”

“Dammit.”

“Speaking of this, you received about 12 proposals, correct?”

“...”

“Hmph.”

“...”

Lloyd realized once again that he should not brag before gorgeous men. He shuddered as he accepted his reality. Just then… *Knock knock.*

“Someone is here to see you. I will open the door.”

The knocking sound was followed by the voice of one of the maids in the count’s manor.

The door opened. Lloyd thought until then that it was another stranger asking for his hand in marriage like everyone else. He turned to the hospital door believing that and found himself flinching when he saw his visitors.

“You scoundrel!” shouted someone abruptly.

The stranger strode fast across the room and pulled Lloyd into his embrace without leaving any time to think.

“You brat, what did I tell you? I’d reminded you so many times not to take part in dangerous affairs.”

Hug!

“Eh...?” Lloyd snapped his eyes open.

It was Baron Frontera who came along with his wife. Lloyd never expected to see them here. Two of them were whimpering, tightly hugging Lloyd in the ward.

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Chapter 79: Rise to Fame (1)

“My goodness, what did I tell you? I’ve reminded you so many times not to take part in dangerous affairs.”

“Eh...?”

Lloyd couldn’t make sense of things for a moment. He wasn’t in the Frontera barony. He was in a sick ward in Count Cremo’s manor in Cremo, the city of commerce. So he had to ask...

What’s the baron couple doing here? Feeling flustered, Lloyd gazed up to find the baron couple smiling at him as though they were about to burst into tears. Lloyd wasn’t spared any moment to ask questions. The baron hurried and forcefully wrapped his hands around Lloyd’s cheeks.

“Let me see,” the baron said, “Are you hurt?”

“I, uhm, it’s...”

“Speak now,” the baron demanded.

“Do you feel uncomfortable anywhere?”

“Eh, uh, uhm. Nothing really in particular, but-”

“But?” interrupted the baron impatiently.

“I can’t really breathe well because of how you’re smashing my cheeks.”

“Oh... Oops,” said the baron as he flinched and released the grip of his hands. His behavior instantly invited a wave of nags from his wife.

“How could you act like that when he’s sick? What if you hurt him more?” scolded the baroness.

“Uhm... I was just in such a hurry... Anyway, are you all right?” the baron said as he looked at Lloyd.

“Oh, yes. I’m fine.”

Lloyd spoke, a wry smile inevitably forming on his face. The baroness was gazing at Lloyd even while reprimanding her husband, who clumsily and naturally avoided the criticism by tossing a question at Lloyd. Lloyd was glad to see both of them. On the one hand, however, a pang of pain shot through his heart when he saw that they weren’t in their best state.

They must’ve rushed all the way here traveling through day and night. The baron and the baroness kept clean and neat appearances at all times. But it was different right now. Their clothes were marked with splotches and dots, and there was even dirt on their elbows and knees. Lloyd could clearly see how they dropped everything to come here. They must have rushed into this ward as soon as they arrived at Cremo without bothering to even change their clothes.

“Did you, by any chance, get the news from Count Cremo?” asked Lloyd, guessing what seemed likely.

The baron nodded and replied, “Yes, you’re right. His Excellency has sent us a letter.”

“What did he write in there?”

“That you are in a critical condition,” said the baron grimly.

“Woah,” exclaimed Lloyd.

“And he told us in brief what you have done in the past few months. That’s why-”

“We departed at once the day we recieved the news,” the baroness cut in, finishing his sentence.

The baron couple’s words were exactly true. About ten days ago, the baron and the baroness were spending time like any other day, finishing up the ondol construction as per Lloyd’s favor and inspecting the water supply system that provided water to the viscounty. And, they also prayed for

Lloyd’s safe return from the travel. The said letter had arrived that afternoon, bringing the news that struck them into shock. Lloyd was in critical condition. The words that followed before and after lost all meaning as they processed the terrible news. The parts about the Gigatitan laying an attack on Cremo and the heroic exploit of their son against such a monster and about how his valor and sacrificing spirit would inspire the others... Blah blah... None of those flowery words mattered to them. Not at all. Only two pieces of information echoed through their head. Lloyd was in critical condition, and the letter was stamped with a magical insignia of Count Cremo. In all seriousness, something terrible had happened to Lloyd.

Their hearts sank. There was no time to waste. So they saddled up right at once. Carriage? Relying on that thing had the potential of tying them down on the road if its wheels went bad on the snowy and icy roads. As such, they hopped on the horses themselves, taking only one knight for protection—Sir Bayern.

They galloped throughout the afternoon, and at night, they relied on the torch and moonlight as they continued to speed up. The travel was hectic and even the horses carrying them were almost knocked out by the fatigue. But the baron and the baroness didn’t feel any exhaustion. They instead galloped off, leaving very little time for sleep. Eating took place on as they were riding on their horses. And nine days later, they finally made it to Cremo.

But they didn’t have the mind or time to work on their appearances to look presentable. They roughly brushed through their matted hair and sprinted to the count’s manor. And at last, when they arrived, they heard the news that Lloyd had woken up while they were traveling to this city.

“You have no idea how relieved we were,” said the baron.

“Your mother may be acting all right now, but her legs nearly gave away, and she almost collapsed to the ground.”

“My dear, you don’t have to say that.”

The baroness looked down.

“What’s wrong? It is true.”

“You’re only pressuring the boy by saying so,” she explained. The baron gaped for a second at the realization.

“You should watch your words in front of a sick patient.”

“Ehem. Hmm...”

The baron let out dry coughs without saying anything more.

“By the way,” asked the baroness, “do you have the doll with you?”

“Excuse me?” answered Lloyd, looking at the baroness.

A doll? What could she possibly be talking about? Lloyd, who had been listening to the story of how the couple arrived here, cocked his head to the question. It was only after he heard the follow-up explanation from the baroness that he remembered the doll she had mentioned.

“I am talking about the talisman I gave you before you left home.”

“Oh.”

Then it dawned on him what it was. It was the uncomfortably large pink doll that was supposed to block nightmares if he hugged it to sleep at night. Lloyd found himself gulping drily.

“That doll should be, err, at the inn,” replied Lloyd at last.

“At the inn?” repeated the baroness.

“Yes,” said Lloyd, feeling that he needed to do better with his response. So he added, “I was staying at the inn prior to this whole ruckus.”

“So is that why you didn’t bring it here?”

“Yes.”

“Wait, have you not used it even before?” inquired the baroness, her voice shaking.

“Um, well, of course...”

Of course, I didn’t. I was rather scared that I’d get nightmares of the pink teddy bear if I slept with it. But Lloyd didn’t say his thoughts out loud. Nothing good would come out of it if he did.

The baroness, now wearing a regretful expression on her face, said, “My, I suppose you did not like the doll.”

“Uhm, to be honest, no, I didn’t like it too much.”

“I shall,” the baroness declared, “then make you a bigger one.”

“What...?” Lloyd gasped.

Excuse me? What’s she saying? Lloyd suddenly had a bad feeling about the situation, and that premonition turned into reality, to his misfortune.

The baroness put on a gentle smile as though she had everything in control and spoke.

“I gave it to you, so you could use it as a lucky charm, but you didn’t. I posit that it was too small for you. That is why I am telling you that I shall make a much larger and fluffier one so you can hug it with ease.”

“...”

“Would you not like that, either? Then shall I attach a ribbon-”

“No, it’s fine. Absolutely fine,” Lloyd hurriedly cut in.

A wry smile forced its way onto Lloyd’s face. To be frank, the attention and affection made him uncomfortable. But at the same time, he found himself touched by how they put aside their usual dignity and formalities and showered him with love. They prompted Lloyd to recall his childhood in South Korea.

I felt exactly this way then. When he was young, Lloyd's father used to be slammed with work. Meeting him happened on rare occasions because he was always working. And on seldom cases where he was at home, he spent most of the time sleeping. Lloyd wanted to play with him each time he was at home. But Lloyd held up, taking heed to his mother's words that Father needs to take a good rest.

But one day, when Lloyd was probably about seven years old, he was riding the kick scooter in front of his house when he fell down. The fall hurt his forehead pretty badly, and with a bit of an exaggeration, it left an egg-like bump on his forehead. This got Lloyd to go back home crying, and the sound instantly woke his father up. Father was sleeping in his room because it was his day off.

Lloyd's father rushed him to the hospital, and on the way home, they stopped at a nice restaurant. The taste of the tonkatsu stuck in his memory even now, and so were the conversation they had and the concerned expression and voice of his father. They were all clear. That day, Lloyd felt in every fiber of his being how much his father cherished and loved him. He wasn't a man who valued work over his son.

"Whew."

Heaving a heavy sigh, Lloyd tried to shake off his emotions before they developed into tears. And he looked at the baroness and said, "Thank you. So how big do you plan to make that doll for me?"

"Presumably, this big?" said the baroness as she beamed and opened her arms wide.

Lloyd's smile brightened as well when he saw her do so.

"Yes, that seems to be a perfect size," he said.

"I know, right?"

"Yes, so what do you say to make another one since you will be working on one anyway?"

“One more?” asked the baroness.

“Yes.”

“Why, do you plan on hugging the two in sleep?”

“No, it’s not that,” Lloyd said and shook his head. He then pointed at Javier, who was standing beside his bed.

“I wish Sir Asrahan to have one as well. He goes through so much to protect me all the time.”

Flinch! Javier, who was watching the union of the family with a calm expression, flinched slightly in the shoulder. And when the baroness praised Lloyd for having such a kind heart, his Adam’s apple fluctuated visibly. Lloyd smiled, his smile growing vicious like the sirens that drag people to misery. Joy is for one, while tragedy is for many, thought Lloyd to himself. A shameful act became less shameful when it wasn’t done alone.

♣

A few more days passed. Lloyd’s health recovered as days went by. The contusions that marked all over his body healed quickly, and the strained and torn muscles returned back to normal. His recovery was a combined effort of the hearty care of the baron couple, nurse, triple circle, and manaheart. There was a massive difference in his healing speed between now and then. The physician watched in amazement as he checked Lloyd’s body.

“You have completely healed. You could even go out hunting on a horse right now,” declared the physician.

“Is that so?” asked Lloyd.

“What about my heart?”

“It beats normally.”

His heart seemed to have stopped when he was in a coma, but now, it was beating perfectly fine. Lloyd had told Javier a part of the secret behind such a miracle, and no one else. To others, he simply played ignorant, saying that he was in the dark just as much as everyone else was. And thanks to his feigned ignorance, the matter behind his heart remained a mystery to everyone. Not only that, Lloyd even confessed that he had no idea how he'd killed the Gigatitan. Heck, he explained, he didn't even know if he actually was the one behind the killing. Sure, he had fought hard until he passed out. Once he woke up, this happened. Even with a such story, some people gazed at Lloyd with doubts, but what else could they do when he played innocent? When he plastered on a thick-skinned a few more times, no one questioned him about the Gigatitan anymore.

Of course, they'll still think that I caught the monster. But they'd believe that I am loathing to reveal the secret. Yes, that's exactly what I want. In the first place, all of this happened because of the mana circles. But not a single person, minus Javier, knew about the existence of mana circles. So it was unnecessary for him to tell them about it. Thinking that, Lloyd stepped out of sickbed and walked out of the manor. He then headed to the city district and stood on the podium. He took a full view of the plaza that spanned ahead of him.

"Huraaaaay!!!"

The plaza was jam-packed with people. The crowd could not be counted. The merchants, pier workers, sailors, fishers, scholars, carpenters, and children... Every citizen born and living in Cremo gathered up, cheering at the podium.

There was more. Trumpets played a clear and majestic song at both sides of the podium, and tiny colored papers were sprinkled from the building roofs that followed along the plaza outline.

Woah. I feel so cool right now. Suho Kim who had nose-bled every day in his tiny dorm room in South Korea. He never expected that a day would come when he'd be treated with such splendor. A part of him felt uncomfortable and jittery, but a greater sense of satisfaction took over him.

The accomplishment was achieved out of pure coincidence, but still, it was an accomplishment nonetheless. He told himself that he should act confident when he was being adored. He must not be shy. He must be chill. Resolving such in his head, he looked to the side to see Count Cremo nod his head as he stood beside the podium. The magic marble that amplified the speaker's voice was ready. Picking up the marble placed on the podium, Lloyd cleared his throat.

"Ehem. Hmm."

His voice rang aloud and clear across the plaza as it traveled with magic. The cheering died down a bit as a result, and now they were waiting for Lloyd to speak. As the silence gradually fell, Lloyd fished a note from his pocket, which was the speech he'd written in advance as per the count's request to speak in front of everyone.

Well, the topic of my speech is obvious. I'm going to talk about how the real heroes are the ones that rescued the drowning people from the waters at that disastrous night. And not only them but also the guards and citizens who sweated over to save those who were pressed under the rubbles in the plaza, as well as the medical officers who risked their lives to put out the fire. Lastly, I'll end with how everyone in this city is the true hero for working together as one to overcome the challenge set forth by the disaster or something like that.

The content of the speech couldn't be any more cliche and platitude. So Lloyd was left in two minds. His heart that had originally decided to give such a commonplace speech swayed. It was the people. As he laid his eyes on the crowds as thick as clouds, desire started to creep up inside him. A decision was newly made, and Lloyd clenched his molars tight. He put his lips to the magic marble with the heart of shouting.

"You may know not what they are, but there is such a thing called 'ondol' in this world."

Lloyd's calm voice spread to every corner of the plaza. People cocked their heads to the side. They had no idea what this ondol Lloyd was talking about. Lloyd continued talking.

“It warms your entire house like a hot potato. A furnace isn’t comparable. No more tears streaking down your face or cough gripping you because of the smoke. Moreover, you don’t have to assign shifts through the night worrying about embers growing into a fire by staying close to the furnace and sacrificing sleep.”

Everyone was left baffled. However, it was strangely appealing. The plaza grew quieter. People gave all their ears as they breathed softly. And Lloyd’s salesman pitch invaded their eardrums.

“Yes, I am the one who installs the ondol. But this occasion is not the right time to talk about it, so I shall stop here. If you have more questions, please visit the Frontera barony that sits east of Cremo. I promise to answer your questions heartily and do the construction for you. With that, I’ll go down. Thank you.”

He was tacit just enough to evoke a sense of curiosity, and this strategy was meant to ensure that he’d be flooded with ondol orders later. Once he was done with the speech, no, the ondol advertisement, he gave a bow and quickly got down the podium. Everyone looked dazed, and the count let out an empty laugh. Lloyd decided to act thick-skinned, caring little what their reactions were. He walked over to Count Cremo and casually greeted him.

“Thank you, Your Excellency, for preparing such an occasion before I leave the city,” he said.

The count, on the other hand, said nothing but smiled in a daze. He had heard recently from his source about the ondol. But it never occurred to the count that Lloyd would be brash enough to promote his construction on the podium.

My, I want to have him beside me all the more. The count thought Lloyd something. He was bold. He struck the perfect balance, sometimes appropriate and sometimes bolder. The young man advanced and retreated just aptly to fight for and make his profit.

Not to mention that he’s always on the ball. It was still beyond Count Cremo how Lloyd had killed the Gigatitan. But one thing became crystal

clear, and it was that Lloyd's constructing skills exceeded anyone the count has seen so far.

It's telling from how the artificial ground in the water is still standing strong despite the Gigatitan's attack. The count's gaze traveled to the shore near the port, and he stared at the artificial ground left there. The mermaid statue had been shattered to pieces when the monster attacked, but the ground was nearly fine save for a slight dent in its side. Made of steel bars and cement, the ground could accommodate a new statue right away.

Certainly, a talent like his must not be wasted away in a remote province. The count's gaze toward Lloyd glimmered in secret, and it remained like that even when Lloyd left the city after his speech.

"Godspeed. May our paths cross again," said the count, bidding farewell. Then after escorting Lloyd and the others, he then headed back to his manor right away. That night, his report detailing the abilities and accomplishments of Lloyd Frontera got attached to the carrier pigeon, which flew her way to the palace in the royal capital.

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Chapter 80: Rise to Fame (2)

Fifteen days passed since Lloyd, and the others left the city. The journey back home was peaceful. Not a single snowflake fell from the sky, even though the wind was chilly as the new year started. Thanks to it, everyone traveled happily. Lloyd, the baron, the baroness, Sir Bayern, and the soldiers' footsteps were light. No accidents happened on the peaceful, tranquil journey. And they arrived at the Frontera barony after 15 days of travel. At the same time, Lloyd's vacation came to an end.

Now that I'm home, it's time for me to work! The joy and coziness of being back home were practically nonexistent to Lloyd. He had a mountain of work to finish on his plate.

I should finish supplying the ondol. And there's also the checkup on the water pipes to make sure that they won't freeze in the winter. The villagers should be running out of wood soon after heating their floors since early winter, so I have to get ready to sell bituminous coals.

That was how he would make money and pay his family's debt. It was only after paying his debt that he could live the rest of his life in comfort. A life of indulgence and peace would be promised for his remaining days then. To actualize such a grand dream into reality, Lloyd called the barony's administrator as soon as he was done unpacking.

"You called for me, Master Lloyd?" asked the administrator.

"Yes, I did. I have a favor to ask you."

"What could that be?"

"Can you get in contact with Shiloh and Meatloaf?" asked Lloyd.

Shiloh and Meatloaf. The Scrawny and Fatso. They were the loan sharks who borrowed a huge sum of money from the baron and extorted an unreasonable amount of interest from them.

The administrator nodded and said, “Yes, I can.”

“Then send them a message right away,” said Lloyd, “that I want to meet them now.”

“Is there any other message other than that?”

“That’s all. That would be enough,” explained Lloyd.

“Yes, Young Master.” And the administrator left the room.

A messenger was sent to Shiloh and Meatloaf just as instructed, and in the afternoon, they visited the baron’s manor. But something about their attitude was different from the past.

“Hahaha, how are you doing?”

“Ehem! Ehem! I pray everything is going all right with you!”

Shiloh and Meatloaf watched out for their manners, which had never happened before. And on top of the changed attitude, they were even holding a basket of flowers and a glass of wine as a git. This would have been entirely unimaginable in the past. Their usual foul-mannered and arrogant looks couldn’t be found on their faces, and the reason behind it was simple.

They don’t want to die. Lloyd chuckled as he had the thought. The two had personally experienced what it was like to be threatened by Arosh, the orc warrior. And they were now all aware of the blood alliance between the Frontera barony and the orc Sand and Steel tribe. To orcs, blood allies meant dear friends whose enemies were also the orcs’ enemies. The rule of thumb for orcs was to slay their enemies. The two knew this very well, so they were treading carefully lest they become the enemy of the barony. Wearing a smile on his face, Lloyd sat them down and jumped into business right away.

“It’s been a while. I actually called you both to inform you of good news.”

“Good news, you say?” One of them replied.

Lloyd looked straight at them and said, “I have made a bit of money recently.”

Shiloh and Meatloaf cocked their heads to the side. It occurred to Lloyd just then that the event back in Cremo hadn’t spread to this remote province just yet. He smiled meaningfully at them.

“So it appears that I can repay what I owed to two of you.”

“Pay us?”

“Yes,” confirmed Lloyd.

“Then how much…”

“About half of the entire principal debt.”

“Eh?!” Their eyes widened in surprise. The news shocked them. It was unbelievable. The debt the barony owed to them was not insignificant. It was considerably large.

It shouldn’t be a manageable amount to begin with. How…? Shiloh and Meatloaf had the same thought in their heads. And they also recalled the time when Baron Frontera came up to them to borrow some money.

At that time, the baron was full of himself like now. When the baron visited them, he explained that he planned on buying some land. But he was just borrowing some because he was short of a portion of the land price. Shiloh asked if he was really doing it because the interest rate was high. The baron nodded as if it were fine. He further explained that the land he was going to purchase would soar through the roof. And paying back the loan would be a breeze, given his massive profit. But in the end, the baron went under.

Turns out, the guy who connected the baron to the land was an impostor. These loan sharks got some men to look around, and they found out that the impostor had eloped after embezzling all the investment funds of the baron. Making things worse, the land which the baron invested in was nothing but a false listing, which only existed on paper. The baron was duped in every

degree. But Shiloh and Meatloaf weren't the types of loan sharks who would be compassionate to his mishap.

He judged for himself and borrowed the money, and he's got to be responsible for his actions. Who cares about compassion when they're talking about money? A contract must be complied with, and that's what was terrifying about money. They were extreme sticklers for such a principle, so everything in the contract was strictly adhered to.

The short-term repayment came at a cost, which was a massive interest rate. The loan sharks added daily interest to the principal without a single day amiss. The principal blew up in sum with interest. And with the increased principal, the interest was adjusted accordingly. Interest increased interest, and the principal snowballed. And so, as the baron dragged things and struggled to pay off the interest, the overall loan amount multiplied to an unimaginable sum, which stood incomparably higher than the money he'd borrowed. As such, Shiloh and Meatloaf thought to themselves that he'd never be able to pay the money during his lifetime. A man like that wouldn't be capable of doing so. So all they could leech off from him was to squeeze him to death until they'd get their hands on the manor and some worthy stuff in his inheritance.

That's how we do things. And his manor and other stuff would render way much more profit than the principal we first lent him. So they waited, much like a spider watching a struggling fly caught in her web or like a viper looking down at a mouse whose body was dying as the poison spread in its body each second. But no death came. The baron, who they thought would perish under surmounting pressure, brought out a card against all expectations. It was his eldest son, a once brute, who initiated several projects all of a sudden. And that was when the winds of change began to blow in the barony. And now, that hooligan Lloyd Frontera just declared to them that he can pay half of the entire principal.

"Are you... telling the truth?" Shiloh asked, too incredulous to trust what he had just heard. Lloyd simply nodded his head as if there was nothing strange about this.

"Yes," confirmed Lloyd.

What Lloyd said was most certainly true. He had amassed more than half the amount of the overall debt. Heck, he had actually earned to the point that he still had some left, even after clearing half of the debt.

It's all thanks to Count Cremo. Lloyd smiled, his eyes curling in satisfaction. He thought of Cremo, the city of commerce, with gratitude, for it has left him with heaps of profits. He had sold every bit of the treasure acquired from the orcs, and that granted him a considerable amount of sum. On top of that was the project commissioned by the count, in which Lloyd built an artificial ground in the water. The payment for the construction was considerably larger than initially promised. It was because of the negotiation Lloyd successfully struck with the count the night before he left the city.

"*Do you plan on going back to the barony tomorrow?"* asked the count.

"*Yes, Your Excellency."*

"I am sorry to hear that. I wasn't able to even properly reward you for stopping the Gigatitan."

"If that is the case, could you return the favor now?" asked Lloyd.

"*Is there a reward that you have in mind?"*

"*Yes. Money."*

"..."

"*I ask for twofold of the construction fee for building the platform in the water."*

"*Hmm... Let us settle at 1.5."*

"Did you not just say that you wished to return the favor for my merits?"

"*1.6."*

"*Ha... I worked so hard to kill that Gigatitan..."*

“Whew. 1.7. I can’t give you more than that.”

“Thank you, Your Excellency.”

So the massive profit was the result of a constructive and peaceful negotiation.

“All in cash,” Lloyd remarked.

“I am sure you will need confirmation. Let us go then.”

Lloyd then rose, leading the two transfixed loan sharks downstairs. And there, he opened the vault with Baron Frontera and the administrator who were waiting for him. It opened up to reveal shining gold coins and bars, whose sight prompted the loan sharks to smile ear to ear. And just like that, half of the debt the barony was burdened with was taken care of, not to mention the interest was slashed in half as well.

And this means that half of the water bill I’ll receive from the viscounty will purely be my profit from now on. Lloyd lifted his gaze with satisfaction after punching the numbers in his head. The vault was now empty, but he brimmed with confidence that he’d be able to restock it again. And to do that, he needed to busy himself without a moment of laziness. His days began to fill up with work again.

“Here! Hold it!” shouted Lloyd.

“Yes!”Lloyd had his tool belt wrapped around his waist, and he now grabbed the tool at the construction site for the first time in a while. He was at the construction site of the ondol house he had continually supplied to the barony. This was the last site, so he personally led the effort. From the first ondol contract to the ones that followed, he fulfilled the terms of the contract and had finished all the constructions.

Ding Dong.

[The installation of ondol flooring to the homes in Frontera fiefdom is complete.][You have successfully accomplished the work of introducing

a new method of heating the floors in a province. The residents will adapt to this new and convenient method and be greatly satisfied.]

[The ondol heating system has now settled as the residential tradition distinct to the Frontera province.]

[A new page has been written in the Laurasian continent's history books as the "Frontera Floor Heating System."]

[For this monumental achievement in construction, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 400 RP.]

[Current RP: 1,946]

Wow. A pleasing message adorned the air in front of Lloyd's eyes. This reward was something he had never thought of receiving. On top of the RP, he received some construction fees. The profit was something he never expected, but it nonetheless pleased him. But Lloyd didn't stop there. The profit didn't make him smile for even a split second. He didn't relax and goof around. Instead, he decided to work harder, dealing with things that were left unfinished.

I vacated the fiefdom way too long because of the Gigatitan incident. He had a lot on his plate. He headed to the coal mine, coming and going for several days and making sure that everything was safe there. Next, he checked the construction status of the leasing houses in the Maritz land, as the migrants would live there come spring.

So I must build them well. The migrants who signed the contract to live here were mostly tenant farmers who, though modest, led a stable lifestyle. And they took on this big adventure of working for their personal lands instead of working for others that promised security. They decided to come here, taking such a risk.

I should be thankful to them. They took on a lot of risk to move here. That was what risk was for poor people. Moving out of a rental house or starting

out in another job after leaving. Or canceling the insurance because one's short of cash, even though that would be a great loss. Each of these small decisions meant a tittering adventure on a steep cliff.

One failure, and there was no chance of picking yourself up back on your feet because you had no assets. Someone with a stable life would never understand the feeling. However, Lloyd personally felt what it was like, back in his days in the dorm rooms. He went through this struggle on a daily basis. He could only execute his plans after much consideration when the choice may have looked trivial to others. This feeling of being alone without support and how very opportunity cost translated to your livelihood. Since Lloyd had experienced this personally, he was well aware of the mentality of the migrants in the reclaimed land.

First, I need to make sure that they will be relieved. That's how I can make them concentrate on their work. Lloyd wanted to ensure that they'd feel comfortable, at least during the time they stayed at home. That was the key to encouraging the migrants to exert more effort and build the land into a more fertile one. Lloyd's thinking was that a comfortable home where they could rest was the beginning of settling into the reclaimed land. So, he spent extra care in inspecting the construction of the leasing houses.

More work followed after that was done. He meticulously worked to ensure that the water pipes were not frozen and checked the status of the stored coals. Such a hectic and busy lifestyle continued for almost 20 days, and that was only when he was able to take care of most of the work. But even after he was almost finished with his work, no time for rest was given to him.

"M-master Lloyd!"

Lloyd was walking out of the storage after checking on the coals when the administrator ran toward him in a hurry. And he shouted at Lloyd, his voice shaky.

"Uh, now, you, you have a v-visitor!"

"A visitor?" Lloyd asked casually.

“Yes, Young Master!”

“Then, what’s making you so flustered?”

Lloyd cocked his head to the side, thinking how strange this all was. The administrator was a seasoned worker, and yet he was now stuttering over a visitor. He frowned. *Could it be that a high-ranking visitor has arrived?*

“What is all the fuss right now? Who on earth is it? And if it’s an important guest, shouldn’t you be informing the baron first, not me?” asked Lloyd grouchily.

Actually, Lloyd was about to take a nice, short because he had almost finished everything. So, he frankly felt annoyed to be bothered by this fussy man who should have gone to the baron. The administrator stuttered again at his snobby question.

“I-it’s, it’s... It’s...”

“It’s what?”

“A royal messenger is here,” the administrator said at last.

“A royal messenger? What?”

“The royal messenger of Her Majesty has come from the kingdom.”

“Her Majesty’s messenger is here?” repeated Lloyd.

“Yes,” said the administrator as he nodded hard.

And in a dazed expression on his face, he added, “So, uhm, the royal messenger of Her Majesty wants to see you, Master Lloyd.”

“What?!”

The royal messenger is here to see me? And finally, Lloyd’s eyes widened just like the administrator’s.

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Chapter 81: Rise to Fame (3)

“Since a long time ago, I, along with the great sovereigns that came before me, have worked hard to achieve peace and comfort for the nobles and citizens. In addition, I have personally considered it my duty to build the land that promises a land of relief to the people.”

Swoosh! The royal scroll flapped open with a pleasing sound, and the messenger’s solemn voice pierced into his ears. So Lloyd thought to himself...

Crap. This is not good. Lloyd was now modestly kneeling before the royal messenger, and it was a relief that he had his head hung down. The royal messenger couldn’t see the look of dismay that was written on Lloyd’s face.

Message from the Queen. I feel like this comes with its pros and cons. Lloyd stole a glance to the side, and he found the baron on his one knee in a courteous fashion. The baron’s eyelids and brows trembled. The overwhelming sense of honor. The surging joy and happiness. The baron looked like the first-prize lottery winner sitting in the bank.

But Lloyd could understand the baron. After all, this place was a province. It was merely a barony stuck in the far-flung east corner. This tacky province would never ever see the visit of the monarch unless a great war breaks out or a historical disaster takes place for her to visit. But against all the odds, the royal messenger was here, reading out loud the message personally written by the queen herself.

It’s going to be an honor for generations to come from the baron’s perspective. What else would bring greater joy and honor than this? Lloyd’s expression grew a tad more complicated.

Well, it’s an honor for sure. Honor if we use it right. Lloyd could somewhat guess why the royal messenger was here.

It’s probably because of what happened back in Cremo. Lloyd got the work from the count and successfully created the marine artificial ground. Later,

he took care of the Gigatitan that ambushed the city. The heroic story must have probably traveled to the queen's ears as well. And that was why she wanted to commend his works and reward him.

Sure, I'm happy, but... Hmm. It's a bit uncomfortable. This is the reason why I didn't want to fight against the Gigatitan. Lloyd furrowed his brows, thinking how, indeed, true his words were. It'd have been best for him to come back after successfully finishing the construction subject. Get the construction fee and ask Count Cremo to connect him to the powerful people in large cities so he can get some more projects in his hands. And build a modest reputation that bags him some lucrative amount of profit. This was what Lloyd had in his mind, and that was as far as he planned to go.

That was my line. Right there. I shouldn't have gone further. If I work my head off for a few years according to the plan, my debt will be gone. It was so according to his calculation. Half of his debt was already paid, and the interest amount lowered to a good degree. Moreover, he had the monthly water bill from Lacona viscounty, which covered the interest and some savings. As such, Lloyd didn't need anything more. Doing more would be detrimental.

I just need to clear the debt. That's all. Just stay within the lines where I don't take projects of exceeding scales. Otherwise, I might fall into a mishap where I'll have to work even after paying the debt.

All of this, working and hustling, was only meant to pay the debt. After that, he didn't want to work anymore. No more living hard. He had already done a sickening amount of work back in South Korea. It was tiring. And so, he had not an iota of the plan to spend the rest of his life here in such a fashion. The pearls and golds hardly looked desirable. He merely wanted to laze around his entire life as a noble in this province.

Three fattening meals. Reading books and goofing around. Riding horses if things get boring. Meet a woman who clicks with me and get married. No more trying hard. Just live a comfortable life with my children and family. That's exactly the life I wish for right now.

But this very moment, an unexpected variable was trying to butt in his plan. The first one was the fight against the Gigatitan, which wasn't what he wanted at all. And after some laborious efforts to stay alive, he found himself accomplishing something big, eventually making his name known to the queen.

Whew... What should I do? He was happy, but at the same time, flustered. Just then, he recalled the days back when he was in the military.

I was like this when I was in a uniform. I didn't know then but living a modest middle-class lifestyle is the best way to live. It was true. It must be when he was a private. On the first day of his deployment after finishing the basic military training, the administrative officer of the company shot Lloyd a question as soon as he came.

"*Would you look at that? Degree in civil engineering? Can you shovel?*"

When Lloyd heard that, he was sitting ramrod straight on a chair in the administrative office. And in a loud, disciplined voice that reflected his new recruit spirit, Lloyd yelled that he could do it.

That was the beginning of my misfortune. Lloyd heaved a sigh. His own thoughtless answer became the reason behind his downfall in the military. From that day onward, he was turned into a personal summon partner of the administrative officer. Thrown into all sorts of construction projects, Lloyd repaired the water pipes, guard posts, and outskirt fences and built the football field in the company. The repair work never came to an end. Once he was done with the field, he moved on to work with the laundry drying machine, and then the battalion's food waste disposal. One repair would be finished only to start another.

And later, I was called in for lawn mowing and welding! Thanks to that, he mastered welding, which he had never fathomed of. Stuck in Yeoju, the rear unit in Gyeonggi province, Lloyd spent more time working and building stuff than learning training tactics, even when he was part of the mechanical force. He got on the handcart more than the armored car and got his hands on the shovel more than the rifle. Half of his years were spent as a laborer. And they even tried to make him stay in the military when his discharge day

came near. Indeed, Lloyd received the offer to become the staff sergeant in the military. But he had enough of the military. So he rejected them, which he regretted a little when his life became tougher for him as a civilian.

Anyway, I mustn't put myself out there too much. The rumor of my good skills shouldn't have spread too far. Otherwise, I'm going to get pestered by the higher-ups. Unfortunately, however, that very thing was happening right now based on the words the royal messengers tirelessly read out loud.

"Therefore, the news of Cremo gripped me with concerns... Blah blah... I was overjoyed to hear about the accomplishment of the valor and sacrificing spirit of the young noble and his personal knight... Blah blah... I shall personally honor the achievements of these two men."

Haa. Please do not summon me to the kingdom, or maybe you can call me when things relax around here? Lloyd had to work on the reclaimed Maritz land, and the coal business was about to begin. He was an exceedingly busy man. He internally pleaded to the monarch with all of his heart, but the solemn voice showed no mercy.

"Here ye! To commend the achievement, Lloyd Frontera and Javier Asrahan are hereby invited to the kingdom. The two people are ordered to travel immediately to the royal capital. January Year 617. Declared by Queen Alicia Termina Magentano in Magenta the royal capital."

Fwip! Tap! The scroll made a pleasant noise as it rolled up. There was such a smoothness in the messenger's maneuver that made Lloyd wonder if the messenger had practiced it all day. At the same time, the shoulders of the baron, who was on his knees, shivered. He started to wail in overwhelming sensation, tears streaking down his downcast face.

"Uhm... Waa...! Wa, waaa!!"

"Baron Arcos Frontera, lift up your gaze," instructed the royal messenger.

"Sniff...! Sniff...!"

"You must be proud your son. Truly, you've got an amazing son."

“It’s, it’s, it’s an honor!! Sniff!!”

Ding Dong.

[Your likeability with Arcos Frontera has increased by nine points.]

[Current RP with Arcos Frontera: +56]

[You have earned 90 RP by greatly improving your relationship with the main character.]

[Current RP: 2,036]

Woah. Lloyd sighed at length. At this point, he was out of options. It reached the point of return. *Oh, well. Now that it has come to this point, I have to do it right.*

Things have changed for Lloyd, and he ought to think of ways to draw the most profit out of them. Expediting his timetable for clearing his debt didn’t seem entirely bad. No, it might be better depending on how he used the opportunity. Once he finished adding up the numbers in his head, Lloyd lifted his head, his face beaming.

“I, Lloyd Frontera, accept Her Majesty’s order.”

And just like that, Lloyd decided to travel to the royal capital, which was the same as passing the bar with flying colors just by studying the night before.

♣

A festival was held in the Frontera barony. The time was right as it was winter, the time of the year when fields required only a few workers. Residents warming themselves up on the heated floor gathered up, and the ambiance felt like the village saw a bar passer after acing the test.

Hanging just a few pamphlets on a utility pole would really help set the mood. Lloyd had the sudden thought as he watched the festival. There was so much vivacity now, and for a good reason. This fiefdom had been absent

of dreams and hopes. Lloyd was the young master who gave himself to daily drinking and troubled everyone. But he completely changed one day. Something seemed to have knocked some sense into him because he started to live an industrious life and began several successful projects. He made fortunes, pushing away the dark atmosphere in the barony that fell because of the scammers. And now, the young master received an order from Her Majesty. He was ordered to come to the royal capital to retrieve a large award. That alone made these innocent provincial residents straighten their backs with pride. In fact, it would considerably benefit all the people.

“It’s going to encourage their spirits. Not only that, they will be treated better when they meet others from another fiefdom. They wouldn’t be looked down upon so easily and enjoy some small profits when trading goods.”

“Hmm, I guess you mean they won’t be looked down on for being a ‘country bumpkin’ from now on.”

“Something similar, yes.” Lloyd nodded as he heard his answer. Javier made sense.

After all, this fiefdom is likely everything to the people here. The Frontera barony was their hometown and their livelihood, and this event improved the reputation of the fiefdom. Their fiefdom had received a royal order and award from Her Majesty, which would become a achievement other people in the province couldn’t easily downplay.

Makes sense that people will be filled with pride. I mean, it’s a human psychology for humans to feel proud when a soccer or baseball team they cheer for win in a game. That was commonplace in the modern world. A particular team clinched victory in a champion’s league, with the most popular athlete in the team scoring the winning goal and carrying the game. That surefire guaranteed online forums to go wild in a frenzy. Lloyd had seen it happen many, many times.

Everyone goes berserk even when they get nothing in return. It was human psychology to go wild for a soccer athlete who lives on the other side of the world and has zero connections to them by school, friendship, or family,

absolutely no connections at all. Given that, what did they get out of this happy event in this fiefdom? And the royal order? It'd directly and indirectly profit the people. It was even more so because the man who received the order from Her Majesty was set to become their lord in the future. That was why they were holding the festival in exhilaration. That was why everyone's eyes grew beady and glimmering every time they came across Lloyd, as if he was a member of VTS, the idol group.

Well, thanks to that, I earned additional RP. He had received 100 from the baroness, 30 from Sir Bayern, and 70 from the residents. Of course, the RP was faithfully saved. He thought of upgrading his manaheart skill, but he held back, thinking that he might find himself in a more dire situation again.

Just because I level up my manaheart skill and get stronger, it doesn't mean that it's good. Skills had to be upgraded according to the situations he was in. Lloyd could only respond to various situations only if he did that. It was the case in the ant cave and during the fight against the Gigatitan. As such, Lloyd decided to store his RP like a bear getting ready for hibernation. The only thing that he pampered himself with was some seeds to transform his summon creatures.

[You have purchased 100 sets of sunflower seeds.]

[Purchase price: 100 RP]

[Current RP: 2,136]

Preparation to travel to the royal palace took place step by step. But Lloyd prepared more than the trip. He had a bigger picture in mind. *Since the monarch kindly got me a stage for me to perform, I think it's only right for me to make sure that I make the most out of it.*

With such a decision in mind, Lloyd came up with a plan, skipping sleep for several nights. And at last, the morning of the departure rolled in. And his master plan was ready to take off to completely clear the barony's debt once and for all.

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Chapter 82: The Wrong Answer’s Better Than the Right Answer (1)

“I regret it.”

“Hmm? What do you mean?”

The sun was clear in the afternoon even though it was winter. Almost 15 days into the journey since the departure, everyone had stopped to enjoy a meal. Javier, who was picking at his food with his spoon, blurted out something. Lloyd tilted his head to the side.

“Regret it?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, I regret it.”

“Regret what? Do you regret being born?” Lloyd said playfully.

Javier replied with silence.

“If not, do you have a concern on your mind or something?” Lloyd asked again.

“No, nothing is bothering me. But...”

“But?”

“It dawned on me that I had spent too much time lazing around the past year.”

“Laze around?” asked Lloyd, one of his eyebrows lifting up.

“I have overlooked my sword training too much,” said Javier as he clenched the spoon in his hand. Fixing his gaze at the soup growing cold in the bowl, he added, “To be completely honest, I would like to express my apology to you, Master Lloyd. That is, about what happened back in Cremo.”

“In Cremo?”

“Yes, the night when we fought against the Gigatitan.”

Javier lifted his head and stared at Lloyd.

“I took off with a bold declaration that I would go and battle the Gigatitan,” Javier explained. “But I was far from enough. I wasn’t strong enough. As a result, you had to take the matter into your own hands, Master Lloyd. That put you in great danger, and you almost died in the process,” said Javier grimly.

“Aha. So you’re reflecting your behavior, yes?”

“Yes.”

Javier spoke and nodded. He was sincere about it.

“Had I been stronger or could suppress the Gigatitan on my own, everything would have been different. You wouldn’t have been thrown into danger. That is why...” Javier paused for a second, his eyes glimmering with determination.

“I have come up with a new year resolution.”

“New year resolution?”

“Yes,” said Javier.

“Wow. How grand. So what is this new year resolution you have come up with?”

“Sword master.”

Pfft! Lloyd almost spit out the soup he was eating. Javier maintained his serious gaze as he spoke. It wasn’t that Lloyd thought Javier’s goal was ridiculous. It was never the case. It was the opposite.

His goal this year is to become a sword master? That would be impossible for anyone else, even if they hustled for the rest of their lives. But it sounds

like it's actually going to happen since it's coming from him. Lloyd indeed felt that way. Javier could actually do it. That happened in the novel.

That's what's scary about Javier. An innumerable number of knights had spent their lives in training throughout history, wishing to become a sword master. They risked their lives, fought against each other, and sweated over to internalize the fights on the battlefields. Their lives were literally spent sharpening their swords. And how many of these sword-obsessed people were there throughout history?

I'd give hundreds of thousands probably, but maybe more. On the other hand, how many had rose to become the sword master? *Less than 200.* Yes, indeed it was. According to the official record written in the Laurasia history book, there were exactly 179. Historians said that the number would increase to less than 300 if they included ambiguous records and unverified stories. So throughout history, there were less than 300 sword masters with only 179 of them who were verified.

That's about the same number as the amount of kings in Korea during the Goguryeo, Shilla, Baekje, Goryeo, and Joseon periods. The number of sword masters in Laurasia history was similar to the number of kings in the history of South Korea, excluding the years in Gojoseon, Samhan, Gaya, or Buyeo, whose records were relatively lacking.

That's how strenuous it is to become the sword master. And here was Javier, who set such an extremely laborious feat as his "yearly resolution" and vowed to work hard for it. Had anybody else said it, it would have made them as nutty as a fruitcake. But given that it was coming from him, it didn't sound like a joke.

What a monster. Lloyd was lost in such thoughts when Javier's grim voice pierced into his ears.

"I shall endeavor my best to achieve the goal, so that I won't be surpassed by you."

"Eh...? Me?"

“Yes.”

“What about me?” Lloyd asked, curious.

To this, Javier replied with nonchalance in his voice.

“You have already created the triple circle and reached the level of owning a manaheart on top of that.”

“Oh, yes, I did.”

“I thought to myself that Master Lloyd may appear slow, dull, and dispirited on the outside, but in fact, he’s actually a genius in sword fighting.”

“What?! Slow and dull?” Lloyd’s brow twitched.

“If we’re only looking at sword fighting, yes, that was definitely the case,” replied Javier as if he was saying an objective fact.

“After all, you weren’t a quick learner or exceptionally strong or fast. To be a little more exact, you were below average.”

“Don’t you think that’s the case because you’re setting the standard as yourself?”

“Anyway, it looked like so to me.”

“It’s like I’m talking to a wall...” said Lloyd.

“What’s important is that I was wrong for thinking such. Truly, I never even imagined that you would create a manaheart in less than a year after you start training.”

“Huh. Is this where the conversation’s going.”

“Yes, so I’ve been feeling panicked that I will be surpassed by you, Master Lloyd.”

“What?!”

Hey, mister knight of the blood and iron. There's no way that would happen. Lloyd wanted to tell Javier that he wasn't a genius. He was simply developing things like the Asrahan Core Technique into a skill to invest in RP and enjoy speedier growth than other people. Lloyd could never catch up to Javier no matter how hard he trained. Never. Not in his lifetime. That was true even though he came to possess the triple circle and his triple mana blast was stronger than Javier's.

I mean, mine is just strong in its output. But it's nothing compared to Javier, who can make good use of it. It was true. There was no point in comparing in the first place. Basic stamina and strength, overall physique, mana employment skill—which reminded Lloyd of a solo guitar performance by Jimi Hendrix, reflex sense, ability to use strength, balance, employability, combat caliber, experience, fighting spirit, and overall technique... Javier was better in all of the categories. Analogizing it to a car, Javier was a 31st-century Formula-One car that was advanced and futuristic. Whereas he'd be...

A 20th-century Daewoo Tico with a fighter jet engine. Lloyd was equipped with the triple circle and mana blast, but he couldn't control it. It was like a lottery. That was the objective evaluation he had given himself. *So you got nothing to worry about dude.* But of course, Lloyd didn't say it out loud. There was no reason for him to tell Javier about the RP. Instead, he decided to leave his knight in his misunderstood state of crisis.

It's only a win for me if he trains hard and becomes a sword master early. Javier was burning with a zeal to get better, and Lloyd stole a smile as he looked at him. It began to snow in the afternoon, and the journey toward the royal capital resumed.

♣

The journey ended quickly with no incidents or accidents. The only event worth mentioning was how one of the royal delegation members had been healed from terrible insomnia. It was the result of them overhearing Lloyd's lullaby service. Anyway, ten more days passed, and at last, the whole delegation arrived at Magenta, the royal capital.

“You will have an audience with Her Majesty right away. You are aware of the proper manners you must keep during your audience with the queen, yes?”

“Of course.”

Lloyd and Javier followed the royal messenger. The royal capital was a city of red and white. Nearly all the walls of the building were painted in warm beige color, while the roofs were made out of reddish brown tiles. The path that led from the outskirts of the royal capital to the palace was wide and immaculate.

But the shape of the royal castle is a bit strange. Lloyd threw his gaze to the distant royal castle as he walked through the path with the royal messenger. The palace had odd architecture. He had a vague image of the palace since he had read the description in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* But the actual building held much more uniqueness than the novel had described.

It looks like a half-buried egg or a bunker in Supercraft. It was round, smooth, and flat. At the same time, there was something heavy about its appearance. Overall, it was as if a round and flat bunker was expanded hundreds of time. There were a multitude of different architectural characteristics from previous decades, including identifiable shapes distinct to Middle Age castles. Such piqued interest must have been noticeable to the others. The royal messenger, who was walking ahead, spoke.

“Are you thinking that our palace is shaped in a special way?”

“Yes. Yes, I am,” said Lloyd.

“Understandable,” the messenger said as he let out soft laughter.

“Everyone thinks the same when they see the palace for the first time. Antic and special. Nothing like a typical palace. Tell me, did you think such as well?”

“Not to such an extent,” denied Lloyd.

“I had heard rumors about it.”

“Then have you heard why the palace was built in such a shape?” asked the messenger again.

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded his head, recalling the portion of the novel that briefly mentioned the palace.

“I heard that it’s because the palace was built hundreds of years ago. Was it around the time when this city was called ‘Taliano’? I heard palace got plucked by the same dragon twice during that time when it was under the unfortunate rule of an idiotic king.”

“You are right. The history books speak of the absolute shock of the incident. And so, the royal castles built during the times took such a shape.”

“Was it to not get ‘plucked’ by dragons,” questioned Lloyd.

“It seemed so. Flat and round. No area to be grabbed. I heard that was the trending style in those days.”

“And that royal castle is the last egg-shaped castle that still stands to this day, am I right?” asked Lloyd.

“Haha. I see that you studied your history well. I like you more the longer I’m with you.”

“You exaggerate,” Lloyd answered modestly.

Lost in the conversation with the messenger, Lloyd found himself near the royal palace in no time. The delegation went through a set of complicated procedures before entering the place. Next, they headed right to the audience room, and it was only when Lloyd put on the new clothes that he realized he was in the royal palace.

Whew... Lloyd would be meeting the monarch soon. If Count Cremo was a big shot, the person he was about to meet was the most powerful individual

who had the whole kingdom under her thumb. In other words, she was Lloyd's VVVIP with the most money.

Time to shine. Lloyd repeated in his head the temperaments and characteristics of the queen, which he had read in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Scenarios Lloyd had played over and over again on the way here flashed through his mind one more time. Now, he inspected for the last time the grand plan he yearned to actualize. Some moments later, the monarch, at last, entered the audience room.

"Presenting Her Majesty the Queen!"

Lloyd instantly got on his knee and lowered his head. He heard the sound of the door opening. The sound of confident footsteps. And the sound of someone sitting on the throne. At last, a clear and energetic voice rang aloud in Lloyd's ears.

"Lloyd Frontera and Javier Asrahan, lift up your gazes."

Lloyd lifted up his head and saw a pair of black leather boots beyond the red carpet. He then saw the brown leather pants of rough texture. A used long sword was wrapped around a firm and slim waist. His gaze traveled up to the modest outfit, strong upper torso and shoulders, and immaculate neckline.

The last that came into his view was the face of a woman who seemed to be in her late 30s. She had red hair, which rippled like a blaze of fire. Her emerald eyes brimmed with confidence and dignity, and they shone brightly against its blazing color. The moment his eyes locked with hers, Lloyd almost let out a gasp of admiration.

She's incredible. The monarch of this kingdom, and one of the two sword masters. The ruler of indomitable spirit, Alicia Termina Magentano. She exuded significantly more dignity and confidence than what he imagined from the description in the novel. It was even more so in the case of her voice.

"Are you Lloyd Frontera?" The queen asked as she looked down at Javier.

Lloyd flinched. And he said, “All hail Her Majesty the Queen. I, Lloyd Frontera, have come to salute Your Majesty, the rightful owner of all the lands.”

“You are...?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Lloyd Frontera?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Hmm. How strange. From the looks of it, he looks more like a noble,” the queen said as she looked at Javier.

“...”

“Moreover, he seems to qualify to try a duel with me based on the aura I am getting from him.”

This time, Javier flinched as he paid his respect to the queen beside Lloyd. It had been only a few seconds since they met, but she saw through Javier and his level. Truly, Javier thought to himself, she was sharp-sighted, befitting the reputation of the sword master. Queen Magentano lifted her red eyebrows and spoke.

“Regardless, I have heard from the loyal and heartfelt testimony of Count Cremo about your heroic feat. Therefore, I commend the valor and the spirit of sacrifice you have demonstrated in Cremo city. However...”

The queen’s emerald eyes grew serious.

“I never hastily judge a person based on a word I hear from another. I trust only my eyes and nothing else. Therefore, I am filled with greed to confirm your abilities. Starting with you, Lloyd Frontera.”

“By ability, Your Majesty, please enlighten your dull subject what it is you wish to confirm,” answered Lloyd.

“It is simple. I have heard that your civil engineering skills are beyond exemplary. Therefore, you should come up with a wise answer to my question.”

“Yes, Your Majesty. I am at your service.”

The queen chuckled softly and asked a question.

“Lloyd Frontera, what do you think is the most urgent construction project that is needed here in Magenta?”

The queen’s smile was now meaningful. She had actually taken interest in Lloyd ever since she read the report from Count Cremo about his abilities.

Prove yourself. Then, I shall personally put you to good use. Queen Magentano stared at Lloyd with an answer in her mind. Her eyes flashed with a yearning to have a young talent around her. But, right at this moment, she was absolutely clueless as to what was happening. Lloyd was under her feet, respectfully looking down as he bowed his head. But he was smiling satisfyingly.

The time has come. It was just as he expected. Lloyd had analyzed over and over again his travel here. He went over whatever he could remember about the novel and inspected the rumors and records regarding the royal palace he had gathered. And so, the queen’s most wanted construction in the royal palace was already at the back of his mind. And now, the queen was asking the very question he had come prepared for. It felt like he was taking a final exam that only had questions he studied the night before.

So now, it’s time for me to grill her. The corners of Lloyd’s lips rolled slightly upward, and he wet his lips. He placed more force on his tongue.

“To dare answer your question, Your Majesty...”

Lloyd slyly began to speak. The queen was the biggest client of his in the entire kingdom, and Lloyd made his bid for victory to get construction requests by fulfilling all her desires.

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Chapter 83: When Wrong Is Better Than Right (2)

“It is my humble opinion that we urgently need to build a new bridge on the Magena River that flows over the whole capital.”

The audience room was spacious but not too luxurious, reflecting the queen’s generous and broad-minded character. Lloyd’s voice rang aloud in the space, and Queen Alicia Termina Magentano’s brows twitched.

“A bridge?” she asked.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Do expound more,” she said.

“Yes, Your Majesty. I heard that the bridge built on the Magena River crumbles quite regularly.”

“Quite regularly...?”

This time, her brows furrowed.

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd’s voice remained calm nonetheless.

“Are you not exaggerating?”

“From a civil engineering perspective, it’s considered frequent when something crumbles once every couple decades.”

“Is it...?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” answered Lloyd, who brazenly plastered an emotionless expression on his face.

Nonetheless, what he said was true. When something crumbled once every couple decades, it was considered “very frequent” from a civil engineering point of view. The bridge that was built over the Magena River fit the bill.

This issue is brought up several times in the novel. Even more, three years from now, this bridge will crumble again after a couple of decades.

The passage about the royal capital burst into his thoughts. The Magena River never saw a shortage of water throughout the four seasons, and the abundant water source brought prosperity to the city for eons. However, that very blessing simultaneously was a curse.

Each spring, the river gets flooded because of the rainy spring season in the east. Not only that, as the massive heaps of snow in mountain peaks melt during that time, the water level gets higher with it.

The spring flood chronically plagued the capital, especially the bridge that laid over the river. Ten years if short and fifty or sixty years if long. The bridge got destroyed by the deluge and the royal chamber spent a massive amount of money on construction to build a new bridge.

A similar case exists on earth, I think.

Heidelberg of Germany. The Karl Theodor Bridge in the Neckar River.

The first version of the bridge was built during the mid-eleventh century by Karl Theodor. But it got destroyed by a flood in 1228. I think a similar thing happened afterward.

It indeed did. The second bridge was destroyed in 1308, and the third and fourth bridges collapsed in 1340 and 1400, respectively. The fifth one was crushed in 1470, and the pattern continued to repeat itself even afterward.

The sixth bridge became a pile of rubble in 1565 because of the floating ice that drifted along a flood. The same thing happened to the next one because of the army of Louis XIV during the Nine Years' War. The eighth bridge was even fortified to become sturdier and more rigid. But it stood no chance when a flood and block of ice hit it in 1784.

As such, some people claimed that the Karl Theodor Bridge of today had ancestors that stretched up to nine generations. A similar event was

happening in the novel, particularly in the royal capital of Magenta, just like what Heidelberg went through during the Middle Ages.

“I had heard that the bridge standing atop the Magena River saw the twelfth construction. Therefore, Your Majesty, it is my modest opinion that building up the destroyed bridge, again and again, is truly inefficient,” asserted Lloyd.

“Are you saying that building up what’s broken is inefficient?” asked the queen in disbelief.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Do you suggest that we put up a new bridge?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“If that is the case,” replied Queen Magentano, “are you confident that the bridge of yours will stand strong even in the brunt of the spring flood and floating ice?”

“Truly yes, Your Majesty,” answered Lloyd.

Lloyd’s voice sounded firm, knowing that times like these called for confidence. In turn, the queen’s gaze sharpened.

“What if it falls?”

“Then...” Lloyd said as he bowed his head lower.

I would run away to a foreign country at once.

Deciding to take on the risk, Lloyd announced, “You may take my neck.”

“Are you serious?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. In return, however...”

“In return?”

“I ask that Your Majesty protect the status of my family until the new bridge I humbly build falls down,” demanded Lloyd.

“Protect your status. That is, until the new bridge collapses?”

“Exactly as you said, Your Majesty.”

By now, Lloyd had practically put his head to the ground. The queen’s eyebrows sharpened as she looked at the back of Lloyd’s round head.

Would you look at this boy.

This boy was the eldest son of the barony that sat in a remote province in the east and yet, he dared to negotiate with the queen. He demanded that his family’s noble status would be sustained for eternity. The sustainment of status could only mean one thing. No matter what happened, the fiefdom would never be confiscated. A lifelong pension that would grant them a minimum degree of dignity. These two were the actual requests hidden behind the outspoken demand.

Come to think of it, he talks as if building a new bridge is already a done decision!

A snort escaped the queen as she thought how deplorable and cheeky he was. This young man’s scheming was too plain and transparent. At the same time, she found his act to be cute and wondered how he could be so brazen in her presence. It was as if he was a puppy whimpering for some snacks to a lion. On top of that, what was the loss to the royal palace to build an unbreakable bridge? This made the queen’s voice slightly softer.

“So, does that mean you have a special plan in mind behind constructing the bridge that will never break?”

“Why, yes, Your Majesty.”

She’s falling for it. She’s almost there, Lloyd thought to herself. He deduced that from the way her voice turned gentle. He was glad that his play worked out.

This is it.

Just then, Lloyd was hit with the characteristic of Queen Magentano, which he read from *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* The ruler of the indomitable spirit, Alicia Termina Magentano. Much like her absolute power and strength, she was broad-minded and unstoppable. Not only that, she was fair and just and opened her ears to the advice of everyone regardless of their status.

Therefore, she despised pathetic, lowly people. Her inclinations are geared toward the type of people who are unabashed and direct in their speech regardless of class, just like how he spoke now. She liked to have that kind of people around her. Eventually, she would lose an arm after getting poisoned by her most trusted person. She would live but lose an arm. The trauma of betrayal would turn her into a completely different person. An atrocious tyrant who never trusted anyone. From a ruler of indomitable spirit, she would descend into a cold-blooded tyrant.

But thankfully, such an unfortunate event hasn't taken place yet.

That would happen three years later, based on the timeline of the novel. At this period in time, Queen Magentano was still bright and just, much like a red lion. So Lloyd thought his bold suggestion would work, calculating that he would have enough of a chance since the bridge-collapse incident was already enough of a headache for the royal palace. Now, his calculation was proven to be right. There was more conviction in his response.

"If we build a suspension bridge in the Magena River, no flood will ever be able to crumble it," Lloyd said.

"A suspension bridge?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

The queen cocked her head to the side. Lloyd made a declaration toward her, this time with more confidence.

“A suspension bridge refers to the bridge construction method suitable for bridges with a vast span. Generally, two high towers are erected tall on both sides, which are supported by a long cable... Blah Blah... The cables are fixed to the anchor blocks located on both sides of the bridge... Blah... The upside of this one is that there’s a pier in the river... Blah blah... Therefore, I humbly request...”

“Stop. Enough,” interrupted the queen.

“Are you done talking?”

“There is more to explain, but I shall stop if it is Your Majesty’s desire...” murmured Lloyd.

“That is enough. I already understand what you mean.”

The queen let out a sigh of disgust unconsciously, wiping off the sweat in her forehead with a handkerchief. She felt as though the explanation she had heard from Lloyd went into her left ear and slipped out of her right ear in one motion. Lloyd’s question turned sly.

“So, what does Her Majesty intend to do...?” Lloyd’s voice was gentle and uncertain.

“What I intend, you say,” said the queen and chuckled. “I have made myself clear that I shall be testing your capacity. You have given an answer to my question with enough confidence. Why else should I hesitate? Proceed.”

“Does Her Majesty mean that I can proceed with constructing the new bridge?” Lloyd asked.

“Indeed. Build it, and prove yourself. If you succeed, I shall reward you heavily, including the merits of yours back in Cremo. However...”

The chuckle on her mouth vanished, and her gaze grew stern.

“The cost of failing the construction shall be as great as your confidence.”

“I shall keep that in mind, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd bowed in respect. It was game on, and he was beyond the point of return. The time has come for him to show what he got.

* * *

“I have never seen anyone so insolent and pertinent in my presence.”

Now, the audience room was empty without Lloyd and Javier. Queen Magentano smiled in a wry manner. Just then, a middle-aged man’s voice was heard as if to second her sentiment.

“He appears clever and calculating, Your Majesty,” said the commander of the royal knights, who was standing ramrod straight behind her all along.

“Sir Kyle, did you notice it as well?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Ha, yes. He is more shrewd than I had thought.”

The wry smile hanging in her mouth deepened. Just then, she was hit with the report she received from Count Cremo. The report made an evaluation of Lloyd Frontera in such way:

“A cunning talent who will surprise everyone by utilizing everything in his power if a clear profit is at stake.”

“He indeed knew what the report said he was, but I never expected him to come up with such a wrong answer,” confessed the queen.

“By the wrong answer...”

“I mean about my question and the answer Lloyd Frontera gave,” the queen expounded.

“Is Your Majesty speaking about the urgent construction of the new bridge over the Magena River?”

“Yes.”

“If you say that is the wrong answer-”

“I already had an answer in mind,” she said, her words as sharp as a knife. In fact, there was an answer at the back of her mind when she tossed the question to Lloyd. It had nothing to do with the bridge construction nor about the deluge or the Magena River.

“I was thinking of the palace repair,” she added.

“Ah...!” Sir Kyle exclaimed as he processed her words.

“Truly, you could not be any more correct. The ten-year regular palatial repair construction is just around the corner...”

“Yes, you are right. It has been constructed way too thick and sturdy to prepare against the dragon. Therefore, it is heavy and requires frequent maintenance. That was the answer I had in my mind. Anyone well-versed in architecture would utter the answer as me.”

However, it wasn’t the case. Lloyd gave an answer that was poles apart from hers. It was absolutely a wrong answer, but it couldn’t simply be considered one.

To be honest, the construction of the bridge over the Magena River was always necessary. But there weren’t really any spot-on measures in plan.

It was true. Her ancestors had mulled over the same issue, which was the flood that regularly occurred in spring when the snow melts after winter. The only method against such a violent natural disaster was a sturdier bridge. So, they constructed a new bridge that was sturdier than the one before each time the bridge collapsed. The same thing took place after some decades. The reason behind it was simple, and it was because of the engineering dilemma.

The builders told me once that the piers that support the bridge must be constructed with more strength and thickness for a sturdier bridge. But the thicker and sturdier the piers become, the greater the water pressure they receive.

Although she was almost ignorant when it came to construction, she was able to grasp the part the builders reported to her because the behind principle was simple. Piers are the pillars that support the bridge legs that stand in the water. So, they are exposed to the constant pressure of the flowing river water. What would happen if the piers thickened and widened? The spaces that receive the pressure of the flowing water would widen.

To overcome that, the builders attempted wedge-shaped piers. They even installed a wooden facility that would protect the piers from drifting ice blocks. However, they were nothing but band-aid measures because they fell short of protecting the flood. Each time the deluge struck the bridge, it helplessly collapsed, and people eventually resigned and gave up.

All they could do was rebuild it as robustly as possible. Once it broke, there was nothing else to do but redo the construction. They regarded it as a tax they pay to the power of nature on a regular basis. That was the policy Queen Magentano upheld for the Magena River. Therefore, Queen Magentano never held an iota of expectation Lloyd would come up with an innovative measure. She never even imagined he could.

But Lloyd Frontera provided the solution in his answer to my question.

The queen had an answer she wanted and Lloyd gave a wrong answer. It was wrong, but it was better than her original one.

I shall stay put and watch first.

Queen Magentano decided to watch the construction of the suspension bridge Lloyd had talked about and observed his ability. If he’s proven to be capable, then she will make great use of him. Filled with the expectation from the queen, Lloyd began to prepare the construction of the bridge.

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Chapter 84: Julian Frontera (1)

“Let’s start from here.”

It was an exceptionally bright afternoon. Lloyd created a shadow with his hand to protect his face from the blazing winter sun. He narrowed his eyes under his makeshift shadow and surveyed the Magena River.

Measure. Crackle...! A mysterious aura filled Lloyd’s eyes, and the sight in front of him changed just then. Countless pieces of data floated on the scene straight ahead of him, and it was like he was looking at the world through augmented reality technology. Thanks to this skill, Lloyd was easily able to figure out the topographic information of the land that spread along the Magena River.

The sloped river bank is covered with flat stones. There’s a road for people and carriages to travel on the bank, and right across the road is occupied by buildings... Hmm, this seems like a challenge.

The Magena Rive flew through the center of the royal capital, much like the Han River in South Korea. But one thing was different, and it was that the river was closely flanked by the city district. The distance between the roads and houses and the river bank wasn’t much, and quite a lot of areas were only about three feet apart.

In that sense, this river’s more like the Seine River of Paris, France, or the Danube River of Budapest in Hungary. It wasn’t that he had been to Paris or Budapest. But he did encounter them when he read materials about city development. Anyway, the crux of the matter was that this place he had just surveyed was far from being unpopulated. It was poles apart from the river banks that remained uninhabited and untrodden. Just then, a horse-drawn carriage passed by, the horse neighing and coughing and heaving a sigh. And to top it off, she relieved a heavy lump of feces on the road and clip-clopped away.

But that wasn’t the end of it. Several groups of merchants walked past Lloyd, which reminded him of Hongdae street on Friday night. Even more,

several clusters of people suddenly stopped dead in their tracks and started to murmur among themselves, throwing a gaze at Lloyd's side.

"Oh, my! Would you look at him?"

"How can a man be as handsome as a sculpture?"

"The sun is shining brighter because of him..."

"Hmm, how handsome. His face shines in handsomeness, much like when I was young."

"My lord, you still shine even right now."

"Hahaha, is that so?"

"Yes. Your balding forehead does shine bright against the sun."

"Hmph! Tell me, do you wish for today to be your last day at work?"

The people continued to gush all around them. Dozens, hundreds of sets of eyes, both men and women, glimmered in adoration, and they were fixated on one thing. Javier.

Woah, this is nuts. Lloyd heaved a heavy sigh, and he threw a blaming gaze at Javier beside him.

"Hey," Lloyd called.

"You called for me, Master Lloyd?"

"Yes, I did."

"What can I do for you?"

Javier spoke nonchalantly with a straight face. Lloyd bitterly retorted at Javier, saying, "What can you do for me? Well, can you keep a distance when you follow me?"

“Excuse me?” Javier arched one of his brows.

“Excuse me, my ass. Will you look over there?”

“…”

“What do you see?” asked Lloyd.

“I see people,” Javier said casually.

“Right? And what are they doing?”

“They are murmuring as they look at us.”

“I am sure you can hear every word among the murmurs, right?” asked Lloyd.

“Of course.”

“So, do you not feel anything?”

“I do,” Javier replied nonchalantly.

“I think I should get a basket before we go back to the quarters in the palace.”

“A basket?”

“Yes.”

“Why?” Lloyd asked, the corners of his lips gradually rising in contentment. He was surprised to hear that Javier would come up with such a thoughtful idea. A sense of pride rushed through him. Even now, the groups gushing over Javier’s appearance were quickly growing. Lloyd was distracted by Javier’s groupies, who seemed to be seconds away from forming a fan club. They were getting in the way of surveying.

“Do you plan on wearing it and covering your face?” Lloyd added.

“Since you plan to wear one, it’d be good if you cover yourself with a large basket.”

Lloyd beamed as he threw a joke. However, Javier didn’t laugh for some reason. Instead, he simply quirked his head and spoke as if he couldn’t understand what Lloyd was referring to.

“Wear it over my head? Why should I cover my face?” retorted Javier.

“Eh...?”

“I would like to inform you in advance that the basket is not for such purpose,” said Javier.

“Then what is it for...?”

“It is,” answered Javier, “to take the things I’ll receive back to the room with ease.”

“The things you will receive? Wait a minute...”

“Yes, I am talking about my love letters.”

“...”

“When I receive a handful of them, I do not mind at all. But it becomes a problem when they start to stack up. You see, the size of the letters and envelopes all vary. On top of that, there are some women who write something down at the spot and give the letters to me.”

“So,” huffed Lloyd, “you’re getting the basket to carry love letters?”

“Yes.”

“...”

Javier nodded much too confidently, as if there was nothing strange or extraordinary about this whole situation. Lloyd found himself biting his underlip.

Ha, how I despise handsome guys. They were the most cunning people in the entire world. Lloyd wished in his mind that they would get hemorrhoids and better if they suffered from chronic constipation. Holding such a small wish in the corner of his heart, Lloyd spoke, almost growling.

“Fine. Do what suits you with the basket. Just make sure that you keep your distance from me.”

“Why should I do that?” demanded Javier.

“Because I can’t focus.”

Lloyd was speaking the truth.

“Sure, they have the liberty to chatter in groups, but they’re blocking most of the view. Seriously, what’s up with those people gathering around like they don’t have a job?! Don’t they have work to do?”

He huffed.

“I need to take time and go around the riverside and the bank to do the surveying and view at the land. But, look, it’s like they came to a celebrity meet-and-greet or the zoo to see a monkey. Haah, what in the world is this.”

“Are you saying that they’re disrupting your surveying?” asked Javier.

“Of course.”

“Will you be less distracted if I walk keeping some distance away from you?”

“Probably.”

“Then I cannot do what you order me to do.”

“Why not...?”

“It is somewhat amusing to watch you get in a bad mood out of jealousy.”

“What?!”

“It was a joke.”

“It didn’t sound like one. Not at all,” Lloyd said and narrowed his eyes.

Javier, who was still wearing a straight face, replied, “It is a joke. I am your personal knight, and this place bustles with people. I think it is imperative for me to be close to you to prepare for any unexpected situations.”

“And amuse yourself by getting the taste of my foul mood, yes?” said Lloyd.

“Is that how you feel?”

“Yeah. Sure, you protect my body, but you beat the heck out of my mind. How fun, right?”

“You’re right on the dot, Master Lloyd.”

“...”

“Heh.”

“...”

I should just shut up and survey. Berating his fate of having a ridiculously handsome man by his side, Lloyd focused on surveying. In actuality, the onlookers did distract him from doing his job. But since he couldn’t sweep them away, Lloyd decided to move around and pivot here and there to observe and gather data. As he did so, he naturally came to one realization.

There was a reason why the bridge kept collapsing. Several areas around the riverside held traces of regular flooding. He wouldn’t have noticed them with his naked eyes, but the survey allowed a vivid look at them because of the trace ingredients left in the stones and soils.

Though it’s very few, the soil of this city district and the one in another land remain a little just up to the level the river rose. Its alien component is

something I could find in the slope colluvium in upstream.

It seemed that the soil composed of different ingredients that sat in the river upstream flowed down here by the flood and left small remaining sediments with the rising flood. But the water level was higher than Lloyd expected.

When the water level reached its peak, the piers, flat surfaces, roads, and carriages became submerged under the flood. An ordinary stone bridge wouldn't be able to withstand that kind of force.

The beam was the part of the bridge where people crossed, and such a high water level was detrimental to the bridge. Since the structure was long and wide by design, the massive amount of flowing river water put pressure onto the bridge's crossway. Not only that, it was also affected by the buoyancy of the full swelling water. The force of balance that kept the bridge intact was completely thrown off as a result.

And even if that was the case, there was a reason why they couldn't construct a tall bridge.

In order for the stone bridge to be constructed high, the piers that supported the deck had to be equally sturdy and large. But that would disrupt the flow of the river water because of their sheer size, which exposed them to a significant amount of water pressure. The sturdier the builders attempted to construct the bridge, the stronger the water pressure became. Thus, the efforts to build a bigger bridge ironically led to equally high risks. That was the dilemma.

I knew I was smart to argue for the construction of the suspension bridge. Lloyd quietly nodded his head, thinking about the suspension bridge he had asserted to the queen. Most of the issues plaguing this stone bridge would be fixed, and it would evade the misfortune that fell on the bridges that came before. It was because suspension bridges didn't need to be built in the middle of the river.

The river is about 260 yards wide. I think I can erect the bridge towers on both ends of the bank without having them submerged in water. That was the plan. First, he would erect the bridge towers and lay a cable through

them. The cables would be used to support and float the bridge in the air, and that would almost eliminate the possibility of the structure getting struck by the flood. That was what Lloyd had estimated in mind. But, of course, the job wasn't a walk in the park. In fact, in all honesty, it was an extraordinary challenge.

Since Lloyd knew how critical the task was, he isolated himself in his room in the palace since that evening after he came back from surveying. Through the nights, Lloyd engrossed himself in building the suspension bridge. He made countless models and ran simulations to test them out. This process was repeated several times. The most important matter in this design was the production of cables, which were a sort of rope made by intertwining thick metal wires.

"Hey, Bangul."

"Bangul?"

Lloyd was contemplating over how to produce cables when an idea hit him. So he asked Bangul, who was goofing around beside him.

"About your steel dung."

"Bangul!"

"Can you make it come out more thinner than usual?"

"Bba-bangul?!"

"Uhm, if you ask how thin... This thin?"

Lloyd closed his thumb and index fingers near his eye, and it was about 0.2 inches thick.

"Just this thick," announced Lloyd.

"Baaangul?"

"Can you do it?"

“Banguuul?”

Bangul tilted her head in a snobby manner, which made Lloyd wonder if that was a yes or no. Her response was ambiguous. At the same time, she seemed to be wanting something.

So Lloyd carefully asked, “Are you saying you can if I do something for you?”

“Bangul!”

Bangul excitedly nodded up and down. And she gushed forth as if she was happy that Lloyd understood her.

“Bba-bangul! Bangul! Bangul Bangul Bangul! Bba-bangul! Bba-bang Bba-bangul!”

“What...? You need a 1:1 proportion of oil-based clay and stone power clay? And you need sand rich with magnetite, decomposed granite soil, and pebbles?”

“Bangul! Bba-bangul! Bangul!”

“And you’d prefer everything to be made in the shape of a pizza?”

“Bba-bangul!”

“The clay should be spread like a dough? And the others on top?”

“Bangul!”

“Are you saying that while I’m at it, I should get basalt, obsidian, azure stone, talcum, and tin as toppings?”

“Bba-bangul!”

“My dear client, anything else you need? Red clay cheese crust, perhaps?”

“Bangul!”

“I’m glad that’s all you want...”

Bangul was explaining that only the right types and proportions of dirt allowed her to produce thin and elastic metal bars like wires. To his relief, the materials Bangul enumerated weren’t impossible to get his hands on.

“Okay. I’ll tell the people in the palace that I need those materials,” said Lloyd.

“Bangul!”

Lloyd headed to visit the relevant official in the royal palace and requested the said materials, adding that they were essential to building the suspension bridge the queen had ordered him to construct. Maybe it was the mention of the queen’s name. The official told him that it would just take a few days for everything to be ready.

I know it’s a bit much, but those thin wires are a must. That was the only way to produce cables. In particular, the 0.2-inch wire he had requested Bangul to create was essential to this construction project. It would be used to make a Parallel Wire Strand (PWS).

Whew... I think I’m all set for now. Lloyd had been giving up sleep and struggling over the design for a few days after isolating himself in his room. So it was his first time to come outside since starting the project. As the pent-up tensions loosened in his body, Lloyd’s head felt a bit dizzy and empty.

I need to rest my brain for a bit. I should rest today. Lloyd massaged the back of his neck which grew tense and strained. Actually, he still had a mountain of tasks for the project to finish. However, he knew that he’d be the one who would get finished first if he continued this arduous, back-breaking work.

And luckily, I have some other business I can take care of during this stroll. Suddenly, a bitter smile escaped him. It just dawned on him. A reminder he had completely forgotten about as he was engrossed in the work given to him by the queen.

“*Once you arrive at the capital, do give this to your brother. And make sure to tell him that we love him.*”

A memory of the day he left for the capital popped into his head. He also remembered the baron couple’s reminder. They had handed him a huge bundle, which contained all sorts of items.

Homemade bacon slices from the fiefdom, a winter coat, a blanket, and so many other small items... Goodness. It’s not like I’m a bundle merchant.

His smile deepened the more he thought about it. Lloyd could see so clearly the image of the baron and baroness busily getting ready to fill this bag. And so...

I should move around and get some air today. Lloyd returned to his quarters and left again, carrying the large bundle he had accepted out of courtesy from the baron couple. He then cut across the capital city district and headed to the Royal Academy, the Magenta College, in the capital to fulfill his errand.

Julian Frontera was mentioned as the brother of Lloyd in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* He was this unfortunate talent whose time came too early despite his studious years in the academy. And now, the moment to meet this mysterious younger brother was closing in.

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Chapter 85: Julian Frontera (2)

“The person you are looking for is Julian Frontera, is that right?”

“Yes, that’s right.”

“What is your name?”

“Lloyd Frontera.”

“And what is your relationship with Julian Frontera?”

Relationship? Lloyd paused and thought for a second.

“Family,” he finally said.

Since he’s related by blood, Julian was his family. But it was awkward for him to utter the word “younger brother.” It felt strange. After all, Lloyd had never met Julian before, and he never had a younger brother, let alone a brother back in South Korea. The housemaster didn’t make any issues with his response, which relieved Lloyd.

“Very good. Now, please show me the token to verify your identity.”

“Here.”

This part was a breeze. He simply held out the family necklace, and the magical verification device in the necklace became activated.

Flash! A hologram image floated on the necklace. It was the face of Lloyd. He brought the image near his face, and it turned blue. It was a match.

“You are verified. Please wait here for a second,” said the housemaster.

“Thank you.”

Lloyd sat down and waited in the lobby, which was an antique space teeming with dark brown trees and the smell of old books. As he sat all

alone there, a sense of nervousness began to creep inside him.

Julian, was it? Even the novel didn't mention much about him. Julian Frontera, the younger brother of Lloyd. He never made any direct appearance in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Instead, he was briefly mentioned around the time the Frontera barony went up into flames.

When the barony fell, he had no way to pay the tuition. Eventually, he got chased out of the academy and died on the same day it happened. A thief stabbed him with a knife in the back alley while he was looking for a place to sleep.

He fought the thief to protect his mother's pendant. And he was stabbed just like that. The unpopulated area squashed any hopes of survival. The boy, fallen to the ground of the alley corner, struggled until dawn, desperately calling in his feeble voice for help. But no one came. His final breath was in the puddle of his own blood thirty minutes before the sun rose. His death was a futile, unfortunate one. The book even mentioned that his death was more unfortunate because he was a good student at the academy.

His studious nature was all that the book mentioned about him. That was all Lloyd knew about Julian Frontera. He had absolutely zero idea about his personality, likes and dislike, and relationship with Lloyd. Nothing. So he was now getting the anxious.

Goodness. He's not going to see me through, is he? Lloyd dismissed the thought right away. After all, Julian was seeing Lloyd after almost three years. Even if Julian found his tone and mannerism to be a little off, Lloyd simply needed to convince him that it was the years of separation that changed him.

There's the perfect expression at a time like this. Turning over a new leaf. Turning over a new leaf. An older brother who came to his senses. That was the role he was going to play today. Lloyd was thinking over his plan prior to meeting Julian when he heard someone.

"What are you doing here? Why did you come here?"

A grouchy, no, a cold, harsh voice pierced into his ears. Lloyd turned his gaze toward the source of the voice, and there he found a young child who had an air of maturity around him. With orange curly hair and freckles on his face, the boy seemed to be, at most, 15 or 16 years old. His mature impression was even more noticeable in contrast with his physique. He was small, barely going over 5’2. His slim body accentuated his small physique, and the features on his face were cute and small, much like a doll.

That’s Julian? Lloyd simply stared at a baby-faced boy who he thought was Julian, and this made the boy grimace.

“Again, why did you come here?” He was still grouchy and thorny. Lloyd became convinced after seeing the boy’s attitude.

Yeah, it’s Julian. Lloyd had heard that Julian was the same age as Javier. 21 years old. So Lloyd was a little confused when he saw Julian’s much more youthful appearance. But the explicit grouchiness told Lloyd that the boy in front of him was indeed Julian. A corner of Lloyd’s lips rose, and he chuckled.

“Why else?”

Lloyd rose from his seat and took a big step to get closer to him. That made Julian flinch, but his green eyes nonetheless held much obstinacy, which seemed more like a venomous resolution to remain strong and undefeated.

Let’s not get too involved with this kid for now. Lloyd and Julian. Lloyd was in the dark about their brotherhood. He didn’t want to rush into Julian’s life too much just yet. After all, he planned on returning to the fiefdom after building the suspension bridge anyway. The boy wasn’t going to meet a tragic end like in the story, so there really was no reason for him to get too involved.

So I’m just going to tell him what the baroness hammered into my head and leave. Lloyd lifted the bundle and held it out to Julian, who was still glaring daggers at him.

“Here.”

Fwump. A considerably large bag got tossed into his small embrace.

“What, argh.”

It looked like it was heavier than he expected as his two legs staggered as he caught the bag.

“Any place to eat around here?” asked Lloyd.

“Eat? Do you mean a meal?” asked Julian incredulously.

“Yeah.”

“Why?”

“I was instructed to have a meal with you when we met,” said Lloyd coolly.

“Who said that?” retorted Julian.

“Who else?”

What Lloyd just suggested was one of the things the baroness told Lloyd countless times when he departed for the royal capital. Julian seemed to have understood that somewhat even without a proper explanation.

“Oh, goodness sake.” Julian’s nose crinkled.

“This way.”

Julian spoke, turning with the bag in his embrace. He led along the hallway, where there was a cafeteria for the visitors. Located on the first floor, it was a place frequented by families and friends who came to see the students.

“What are you having anyway?”

Julian asked after getting a seat first. Then he started observing Lloyd.

Tsk. Julian instantly retracted his decision to observe Lloyd because his mood soured the moment he laid his eyes on him. There wasn’t any

particular reason behind it. That was how he always felt about his brother.

“I’m telling you in advance, but you can’t drink here,” said Julian.

It was Julian’s way of taking precaution. At the same time, he felt like he was on pins and needles when he remembered the type of person Lloyd was.

He can be thrown to the corners of Hell, and he’ll still go looking for booze. It was Lloyd who had said that his body became all itchy and red if he lived a day without alcohol. And each day, he threw his drunken tantrum at all people. Breaking stuff in the house was commonplace. Sometimes, he hit people, and Julian wasn’t an exception. Arguably, Lloyd whacked Julian the most. When Julian was young, Lloyd beat him for not doing his errands. When Julian grew older, Lloyd beat him for hovering around while he was drinking. His violence grew worse to the point that Lloyd whacked, punched, and kicked Julian for always living an upright life. It pestered Lloyd. That was how much of a piece of trash Lloyd was. He was one of the most disgusting scumbags Julian ever met. And so, Julian couldn’t believe the current situation.

What could that man possibly accomplish? Just then, an event from a few days ago popped into his head. A man from the royal palace came looking for him and shared the news about Cremo, the city of commerce. The city was the center of Cremona, the region where part of his hometown was located. The man had said that the Gigatitan wreaked havoc by arriving on the inland. The sailboats that floated in celebration of the statue construction sank, and the actual statue and the posts were destroyed. Even more, the city district was set on fire.

But no one died, according to the man. Moreover, I was told someone exerted superhuman courage and selflessness to fight against the Gigatitan. Julian was honestly very impressed, and his heart was filled with awe to the point that it began to thump when he heard the story. The reason behind the man from the palace telling him the story was lost in his thoughts. He was curious. He wanted to know the man behind such a fantastic achievement. He wondered what kind of life the man led and what kind of wisdom he held. Julian direly wanted to know more about him, and if he could, Julian

wanted to meet the man and learn from him. Become a bit like him after personally meeting the amazing hero with his own eyes. In short, Julian was mesmerized by this hero. So he did a double take when he heard the name of the hero, which forced Julian to scratch his head in confusion several times.

No way! The hero who saved Cremo, the city of commerce. His name was Lloyd Frontera. Julian couldn't believe it and for obvious reasons. But eventually, he was left with no choice but to buy it because the story was told by the man from the palace. So it had to be true. On top of that, the man reminded Julian that he should not speak of this to anyone for the time being as the official announcement would be made when Her Majesty sent a letter to Lloyd Frontera. His brain felt numb. The longer Julian listened, the more dazed he became. It felt as though he got hit by a hammer in the back of his head.

Lloyd Frontera?! Not in a million years. There must have been a misunderstanding, or something must have gone terribly wrong. Everyone could have gotten confused. If not, they might be enchanted or possessed by something evil.

Those thoughts were what first came to Julian. There was definitely something missing here. Something distorted or misunderstood. It didn't make sense otherwise. His scumbag drunkard of a brother was the last person who could obtain such an accomplishment. He was nothing but a scum who drank every day and got in trouble. That was all he was.

That's what I'd thought... Julian lifted his head and glanced across the table. Lloyd was slowly going through the menu. For some reason, he wasn't browsing the alcohol section. He was simply looking at the food selections with a serious expression. And just then, Lloyd looked up, locking gaze with Julian.

"What are you looking at?" asked Lloyd.

"Eh...?"

“If you want to look at it first, go ahead. I’m buying. This restaurant is for visitors, so it’s not free, is it?” asked Lloyd.

“Y-Yes. Yes,” muttered Julian.

“Then take your pick.”

Tap. The way Lloyd passed the menu. The slight scoff. It all felt too distant and strange. Julian thought that Lloyd was acting odd.

“...”

Julian covered his face with the menu after receiving it from Lloyd. He couldn’t focus on anything that was on the menu. And he started blabbing out words without meaning to.

“Uhm, you see, how’s Sir Asrahan?”

“Javier?”

“Yeah.”

“What about him?” asked Lloyd.

“I heard you came here with him,” answered Julian.

“Have you been keeping up with my news?”

“Yeah...”

Shoot! Why am I having this kind of conversation with that person?!

Julian grasped the menu. *Lloyd Frontera is not ordering booze? But he always cursed and lashed out at me every time we had a conversation that was longer than ten words!*

Since the situation was terribly strange, awkward, alienating, far-flung, severing, and shocking, Julian even let his mind come up with an eerie possibility that the man in front of him might not be his real brother. In

short, he was a bit befuddled. But Lloyd was completely ignorant to what was going on inside Julian. He simply spoke, his tone dripping with much more humanness.

“Well, one thing led to another, and then we’re here. Don’t mind us too much,” assured Lloyd.

“Okay...”

“Oh, did you want to see Javier?”

“Eh...? Yeah, a little.”

“Are you upset that I didn’t bring him?” asked Lloyd.

“Not to that extent.”

“Then, good. He actually wanted to tag along, but I stopped him.”

“You stopped him?”

“Yeah. It gets really rowdy when he’s around. He attracts people’s attention,” said Lloyd.

“Y-Yes, you’re right. He’s handsome and cool.”

“Anyway, that’s why I stopped him. He was being stubborn about it, so I told him that I wouldn’t sing a lullaby to him anymore. That shut him up right away.”

“A lullaby?”

“Don’t worry about it. Anyway-”

Lloyd, who was talking very well, suddenly stopped talking and turned serious. This made Julian flinch. Finally, Lloyd opened his mouth and asked, “have you decided what to eat?”

“Huh?” Julian’s voice was raised a pitch.

“What are you getting so surprised for? I’m asking if you have decided. The menu.”

“Oh, yes. This one,” Julian said.

“Get something more expensive.”

“It’s all right. Really,” Julian assured.

“If you’ve chosen what to eat, put down the menu.”

“...”

Julian wanted to keep his face covered like this. Lloyd’s behavior was making him feel unbearably awkward and uncomfortable. He bit his bottom lip, hanging his head down.

Ha. This is nuts. It had been a long while since Julian met Lloyd. It was an unexpected meeting as well. When the housemaster informed him that his older brother was here, Julian wondered if he had heard it right. And on the way down here, he even made a stern resolution to not get distracted and swayed by Lloyd like in the past. That was why he had acted in such a grouchy manner. He treated Lloyd with as much sharpness as he could muster. Otherwise, that man would either hit him or throw an ugly fit, Julian expected.

I planned to call the housemaster if that happened. The housemaster would have the authority to kick Lloyd out. He wanted to keep the meeting with Lloyd as short and brief as possible. But his plan failed within ten minutes because of Lloyd’s eerily normal behaviors.

Should I just ask upfront why he’s acting like this? To be honest, Julian held many questions for Lloyd. For starters, why was he acting so normal? And what kind of scheme did he employ to trick Cremo people into believing that he accomplished something there? Julian finally lifted his gaze to ask those questions. He then threw a determined gaze at Lloyd, but just at that moment, Julian witnessed something he never expected to see.

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Chapter 86: How To Eradicate Violence (1)

Huh? Julian opened his eyes wide, lifting his gaze after working up some courage to ask Lloyd what had happened back in Cremo. But when he did, every bit of his courage and determination vanished into thin air. Was it because he saw Lloyd's face and changed his mind? No. It was because he spotted a man coming his way from behind Lloyd.

Diego? Diego was his classmate, and they were both the same age. But Diego was much bigger, so he was stronger with a deeper voice. No matter, they got along just fine since they started attending the academy around the same time. But that lasted only a month after enrollment. After that...

"Julian Frontera. Did I not make myself loud and clear that you should not eat where you can be seen in the dorm?"

Diego was already near Julian, and his voice was a low growl. The threatening voice pierced into Julian's eardrum. Julian hung his gaze down. It happened against his will. Diego's robust and veiny hand on the table came into view.

Why did he have to come now? Julian berated the situation he found himself in. He was now meeting Lloyd for the first time in a while and was struggling hard not to lose the power struggle against him, the ever-scumbag. But that was all pointless because he was confronted by Diego, who couldn't seem to ever leave him alone. He had the worst luck.

"Oh, I-I..." Julian stuttered.

"What?"

"..."

Julian bit and chewed his lips. Diego, who was now looking down at Julian, was overcome with hatred. *What a scrawny jerk he is.* Diego didn't like Julian, but it wasn't always the case. When he first got to this academy, the Magenta College, Diego was all alone, and he knew nobody because he

came from a far-flung province. There was, however, only one person that first came up to him. Julian.

"*Hey, I came here last night too."*

One day difference. Similar enrollment. And it turned out that their hometowns were very close. Diego and Julian found a friend in one another, and the two became close. They hung out together all throughout the month, and during that time, Diego was surprised to find that Julian was a bright and intelligent kid. Grammar, logic, law, natural philosophy, geometry, and even astrology... Julian was able to comprehend the studies others found difficult. Not only that, he was dutiful. Throughout the time he'd been with Julian as a roommate, he never saw the latter sleeping in. Waking up an hour earlier than everyone else , he washed up, had breakfast, and got ready for class. Diego was impressed but only for a month.

Intelligence and work ethic. I realized in the first month that you didn't need any of that in this place. Diego scoffed in his head. A snort escaped him when he thought of what he had realized during the first month of school. This royal academy was established to educate noble children, but studying barely mattered to the students here. Something else held greater significance than getting good grades, which was family status. The whole academy was all about forming connections with other families. Engage in school politics with such connections. Build relationships with other families at such young ages and create their own cartel and sanctuary. Maintain it for the rest of their lives, even after they become the bearers of the family name. Continue capitalizing on the formed relationship and maintain power. The secret society of nobles where they supported each other's interests. Their own cartels. At its core, the academy's existence was to lay the foundation for this system.

It's funny, but it's undeniably true. The world was ruled by power. And power was maintained through connections. Work could be given to those who studied hard. When this truth hit Diego, he changed.

"*Starting today, don't act like you know me."*

The first action Diego took was distancing himself from Julian. He warned Julian to stay away from him with a straight face. At first, Julian reacted with confusion because he couldn't understand what Diego was saying. So, as a way to make his point, Diego punched Julian. One bruise on Julian's eye. That shut him up. The reason behind distancing himself from Julian was simple.

He's the son of a tiny rural barony. The lowest among the nobles. No power. No fame. So Diego had zero reasons to be close to Julian. Heck, he was rather afraid that he might hit rock bottom, just like Julian and his family. He believed that was the worst thing that could happen to him.

My family isn't a very powerful one, either. In fact, Diego's family was a viscount. His family's financial situation allowed him to live in clover because of the viscounty's specialty product, but it was nothing compared to the *real* nobles in the royal capital. And so, Diego chose to be a bully and started to suck up to the students who were high up in the hierarchy. He groveled to the sons of noble families, becoming their right hand whenever they needed him. In the process, he didn't forget to pester and harass the sons of lower nobles like Julian. It was a way of drawing the line between him and these lowly nobles, a way of publicizing his superiority over the others. In short, Diego became a devoted dog of the sons of noble families in the royal capital.

That was what was happening right now. A hunter dog was proving his existence by hunting. Diego moved forward, coming within inches of Julian's face as though he was studying his prey.

"I am asking you right now. What did you think when you decided to come to eat here?" Diego growled.

"..."

"Answer."

"Uhm... Uhm..."

"Uhm, what?"

“I had to today... It’s...” muttered Julian.

“Had to? Why?”

“...”

“Are you suddenly excused from the rule whenever someone comes to visit? Is that it?”

“...”

“What did we learn in law? The law is not malleable, and you’re violating it right now,” reminded Diego.

“...”

“What’s the rule here?”

“That’s...”

“Losers from lowly baronies should not eat in public. Why? It’s annoying to see. Did you forget that?”

“...”

Julian’s mouth clamped shut. He clenched his molars. He wanted to fight back, rebut that bullcrap. But he couldn’t do so because he’d only find himself in an uglier situation. Nobody protected him here. He could yell and bawl that it was unfair. But no one listened to him. Why? Simple. The families of the bullies held much greater power. The memories of harassment and powerlessness flooded his mind, suppressing his desire to fight back. Instead of doing that, Julian shot a gaze at Lloyd. However, it wasn’t a gaze asking for help.

Don’t interfere. Julian spoke via his gaze. He asked Lloyd not to intervene in this situation. One thoughtless intervention held the potential to damage his family and wound everyone up in an unnecessary dispute. So he asked his brother to pretend he didn’t see any of it. Lloyd, who was watching over the whole thing, answered with his gaze as well.

Yeah, of course. Why would I intervene? Lloyd shrugged and visibly raised his brows. At first, the whole didn't make any sense to him. But a few glimpses of their exchange granted Lloyd to understand the whole thing. This was also something he had commonly seen in South Korea.

Well, how unoriginal. School bullying. Bullying. School violence. Being born and raised in South Korea, the very scene in front of him was a daily occurrence. Of course, there wasn't necessarily a time he got bullied by the others. But he did witness a lot of such cases. Elementary school. Middle school. High school. All classrooms were operated under a jungle-like system of power. The so-called bullies ruled the turf, while the fawning students never left the former's sides. School life turned extremely difficult for anyone who became the target of those bullies. No, it was much worse. All sorts of inhumane harassment and torture followed them all year. School violence. It was ubiquitous, but everyone turned a deaf ear and blind eye to it. Not a single South Korean student could be freed from it. And this world didn't seem much different.

Well, this is also a place run by humans. Lloyd stared at Julian sitting across from the table. He was short and small and had a bad family name. Of course, when compared to the entire population of the kingdom, the baron status was something to be proud of. However, Julian was in the royal academy. That was the problem.

Only the nobles who get recommended can study here. Julian, too, received the recommendation, and he enrolled here with much support from his family, only to be stigmatized as the lowest ranking student in the hierarchy of the academy.

But Lloyd didn't uncross his arms. He simply stayed put, watching. Was it because of Julian's favor? No. *Let's just watch for now.* He didn't want to butt in thoughtlessly. After all, he was just a passersby who might never return here after today. But what would happen if he meddled and blew this whole thing up? What if he took care of this threatening student and went back and never returned? Julian would be left all alone, and...

It's going to make it worse for this kid. The sense of victory and relief would be short-lived. The harassment and bullying would get even worse.

He had seen it happen too many times in Korea.

So first, I have to find out what's going on. Lloyd's gaze grew sharp as he started his observation. He focused on how much Julian could protect himself in this situation, how bad the harassment was, and the method to cut it off. Without saying a word, he simply detached himself and played the observer's role, wondering in his head what kind of preparations he needed to make. Meanwhile, Diego's behaviors against Julian started to cross the line. Diego lifted his large palm and tapped Julian's small head a few times.

"That's why both you and your family lineage are trash. Got that? Honestly, what have you got in your family to boast of, eh? Fresh air? Clean water? Dirty and poor farmers? What else?"

Tap. Tap.

"But what about my family? We have a specialty product widely acknowledged for its quality in the kingdom. You know it, too, right? Laconata. My father presented the fabric to Her Majesty last year."

Slap! Slap!

"So, please. I beg you to just consider yourself invisible because you're nothing but a scum just like your family. And stop eating in public. Understand me?"

Tap! Thwack! The palm that smacked Julian on the top of his head grew more violent and forceful each time. At first, it was a simple tapping. But now, it developed into a smack.

"Know your place, okay? What are you looking at?"

"..."

Julian accepted the harassment without a fight. The only protection his petite body could manage was clumsily wrapping his head with his hands. Just then, his sleeves rolled up, slightly revealing his arms with bruises everywhere. From old yellow ones that spread out from time to dark reddish

and bluish ones, Julian's arms were a mess. It wasn't the result of a day or two bullying. When his arms came into view, Lloyd made his resolution, and he thought over something he had picked up a while ago.

Laconata. I knew it. I knew he looked familiar. The way Lloyd stared at Diego turned deadly. He quickly went over the situation in his head. The plan was settled. Behavior and consequence. Action and reaction. A complicated ball of string was untangling. Predictions and processes. The ultimate result.

"Tell me, what does that old geezer of your father do?"

Lloyd spoke in a soft but low voice, his chin propped against his hand. That made Diego stop smacking Julian. For the first time, Diego's gaze turned to Lloyd.

"What?"

Diego's brow twitched as he looked at Lloyd. He glared at Lloyd for speaking of his father. *What is this now?* Diego did notice a while Lloyd sitting across from Julian. But he chose to ignore him because he considered Lloyd another scum visitor who came to see Julian. Scums of the same kind grouped together. And so, he ignored Lloyd's existence. But now, this scumbag was speaking impertinently before his presence.

"I am asking. What does your old geezer do?" said Lloyd again.

"Ha! He is Viscount Lacona, the wise and merciful. What are you?"

"What am I? Don't you know who I am?" asked Lloyd.

"What?"

Lloyd was now standing up, facing Diego and his large physique. He smiled icily.

"My goodness. It was like this in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Even though the Lacona viscounty was their neighbor by geography, the lack of engagement made it impossible for the children to know each other's faces.

You don’t recognize me? What was written in the novel was true then,” said Lloyd.

“What are you… Ack!”

Thwack! Just when Diego was about to respond, Lloyd kicked Diego like lightning in the gut.

“Ack!”

The kick contained the strength of one mana circle. Diego’s body folded in half and went flying in the air, smashing two tables in the process and rolling away even after landing.

A corner of Lloyd’s lips rolled upward in hostility. Diego was an unlucky boy. He had picked the wrong place and person to bully. In the very academy funded by Her Majesty, Diego had acted with impudence against the honored guest of Her Majesty. No housemaster or dean could do anything about it. Besides...

“What should I do with you? I guess you haven’t heard from that geezer, the wise and merciful, about the water bill, eh?” Lloyd spoke, his voice dripping with compassion and pity.

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Chapter 87: How To Eradicate Violence (2)

“W-water bill...? Eek?”

Cough! Cough! Diego couldn’t think anymore because of the sudden blow that knocked him out. It hit right into his gut, and it was too powerful. His stomach tumbled, twisted, and churned from the sudden blow. He couldn’t breathe well, and his whole body ached as a result of being flown away. His back smashed the two tables into pieces, so it went without saying that his back was far from okay. However, despite the blow, Diego stood up, telling himself that he couldn’t act weak in front of whoever was that bastard that kicked him away. And besides, he knew who he was. A mana user with a manaheart.

“A-Argh!”

Diego got back to his feet, his face red. He shot a deathly glare at Lloyd for giving him the first blow, only to learn that a fist was flying right toward him at lightning speed.

It’s too fas… Pow! Something blinked in front of him, and his nose ached like he was hit by a hammer. The blow shoved his head to the side before he could react. The time around him started to slow down, and something interesting came to his view.

Is that... my front tooth? A flat, white tooth twirled in the air as it flew away, along with drops of blood and saliva. But Diego wasn’t spared another time to appreciate the spectacle. That was because another merciless punch flew to clock him in the gut. *Pow!*

“Argh!”

Once again, Diego’s body curved inside like the letter “c.” His knees bent by reflex. Just then, his ears heard a cold voice.

“You don’t even know why you’re getting beaten, eh?”

“I, ouch! Ack!”

Thwack! His cheek suddenly felt hot, feeling the thick blow of a slap. The ear on the side dulled, and the world swirled around him. He couldn’t distinguish which was up or down. Even so, the cold voice continued to be heard.

“Do you still not know why I’m beating you? Huh?”

“Arggh!”

Wham! This time, it was his right shin. Diego wondered if the man kicked —no, stabbed—him with pointy shoes. Or was it another object? He couldn’t tell. The bone in his shin hurt too bad. He bent over by reflex, lowering his arms to the ground. However, the voice was heard once again.

“Viscount Lacona, the wise and merciful? I have to laugh.”

Thwack!

“...!”

Diego was looking at the restaurant ceiling. He wondered how on earth he was looking up. Did his head get lifted up? And why, Diego thought to himself, does his jaw hurt this bad?

“How are you so similar to your father? Hm? Tell me, is bullying vulnerable people something that runs in your family?”

Crack! This time, the blow hit his left collarbone. It slammed into his bone without a tad of mercy.

“Ack...!”

He had never experienced this type of pain before. His mouth hung wide open against his will, and his curled tongue scratched his palate in desperation.

Why? Why?! Diego couldn’t make sense of this situation. He was a mana user who received swordsmanship lessons from the fiefdom’s senior knight starting from when he was 11 years old. The tenacious mana training allowed him to create a manaheart just within four years. The stupefied look of the senior knight stuck in his memory. Sir Curno asked him at that time if he was a genius. And so, Diego was confident that he had the upper hand because of his manaheart when it came to fist fights and scuffles. That was why he had no one to be afraid of at his age. But now...

How, how dare he?! Arghhhh!! Diego went livid. It hurt too badly, and so he attempted to counterattack, flailing his clenched fist. But the man didn’t even try to avoid it.

Thwack! Lloyd’s head turned at the blow, and a smile of hope appeared on Diego’s face. *Do I stand a chance? Do I?*

But it only took three seconds for his hope to shatter into pieces. Lloyd, whose head was shoved aside, slowly recovered and looked at Diego. He then wiped his torn lip with the back of his hand and flashed a vicious smile.

“Now, it’s mutual combat.”

Thwack! Whatever mercy was left in Lloyd’s blows vanished. It was time for a ruthless beating session. Lloyd punched, punched, and punched again. He was knocked down with his elbow on and on. And there came the kicks. He kicked only to throw another kick. When Diego fell to the ground, Lloyd rose him up and beat him even more. When he resisted, Lloyd kicked, punched, and struck him. Diego pleaded. Lloyd ignored him and trampled him some more.

“S-stop! I’m sorry! Stop!”

“Stop, my ass,” huffed Lloyd.

Thwack! Pow! Bam!

Diego lay coiled on the ground. Lloyd stomped on his back, head, and anywhere his foot touched. Lloyd looked at Diego, calculating every kick and punch against him in his head.

This is the only way to make sure that this boy won't hurt Julian again. Diego was set to bully Julian again if Lloyd went easy on him. So he had to do it right. No half-assed forgiveness. He needed to go all out in beating him. Lloyd was sure about that because he had his share of experience back when he was a student in South Korea.

This is the most effective solution for guys like him. Just then, a past memory interrupted his thoughts. It must have been when he was a first-year student in high school. There was once a bully in his class, and one time, the bully set Lloyd as his target. And so, he had used this very method to completely resolve the problem. He had said no to the bully ordering him to get some bread from the cafeteria. The bully then slapped him with a pair of slippers. Three slaps for each cheek, totaling six. Two blows in his gut. Once he got them, Lloyd said yes but instead headed toward the back of the classroom, where he found some elongated fluorescent light bulbs to be disposed of later. Lloyd grabbed one of them like a bat and walked over to the bully, who was happily chatting with other bullies. Lloyd raised his hand, and he struck the lightbulb right on the back of the boy's head.

Clang! Clash! Blood flowed everywhere. All hell broke loose in the classroom. But Lloyd didn't stop there. He had to do it right. Repeating those words in his head, Lloyd lifted one of the chairs and smacked the bully with it. He then trampled him.

That day, the bully was sent to the hospital while Lloyd got suspended. Parents were called in, and they apologized to the bully's parents for putting their son in the hospital and generously compensated them for the medical bills.

Surprisingly, nothing more happened after that incident. There were just a few rumors saying that Lloyd was a nutcase. That was all. He enjoyed a quiet, peaceful life until he graduated high school. Not a single student ordered him to get some bread. Though the measure Lloyd had employed

involved severe violence, it granted him immunity from school bullying or abuse.

It's the same now. You mess with Julian, and you die in my hands. You speak ill of my family, and you die in my hands.

The punches and kicks Lloyd threw at Diego contained such messages. Each time Diego's body received another bruise, Lloyd ensured that such lessons would be implanted in his wounds. Julian's heart sank in shock as he watched everything.

Lloyd, that idiot, has lost it! Julian's jaw dropped. The sudden desire to hide his face rushed through him as he witnessed the violence happening in front of him. Was it because he was shocked? No. It was because his future was growing bleak with every second.

I knew that Lloyd Frontera was a nutcase before... But what in the world is he doing right now?! Julian had sent several gazes at Lloyd to stay away from this. He had hinted to please turn a blind eye to this. And Lloyd nodded, though faintly. So, Julian was relieved. He had thought Lloyd of a ruthless human being who couldn't be restrained. Human trash that upset his parents. But seeing Lloyd nod, Julian presumed that this man had learned to control himself in a situation like this. Julian couldn't be any more wrong, as it turned out. Control, my ass! Julian thought to himself. Lloyd was beating the daylights out of Diego like a man who lost it. No, he was beating Diego closer to death!

"Hey!" Julian yelled, unable to hold back any longer. "Stop it!"

Lloyd had to stop. Indeed, he really had to stop now. He had went too far already. Julian wondered how Viscount Lacona would react when he heard that his son had become a ball of bloodied mess. And what punishment would Lloyd get from the academy for beating Diego? And what kind of harassment would he get more from others in the future? The more he allowed his thoughts to wander, the greater his body trembled like he was in an ice cave. Finally, unable to hold back any longer, Julian grabbed Lloyd's arm.

“I said, stop it!” Julian shouted violently. But the response that came afterwards surprised him.

“Sorry. Just a little more.”

“Eh...?”

Shiver. When Lloyd turned around for a second to reply, his eyes locked with Julian’s. This instantly brought bone-chilling chills to Julian’s body. Was it because Lloyd had a set of murderous gaze about him? No. Absolutely not. Instead, he was more...

Lloyd’s calm. He hasn’t lost a single strand of reason. It was too unexpected. Julian couldn’t wrap his head around this. The man in front of him was poles apart from the Lloyd Frontera, his hooligan brother, he knew. And it was the same case with the answer that followed.

“If I half-ass the fight right now, then it’ll only make it harder for you. Is that what you want?”

“That’s...”

“So, just trust me.”

Thwack! The beating session resumed. Julian was left overwhelmed by the sheer force of Lloyd and his cool-headed violence. And at last, Diego passed out.

Bam! One last punch, and Diego’s head drooped. Bubbles foamed around his half-opened mouth. Countless gazes were looking at them, and just then, the housemaster bawled as he rushed toward their way.

“What?! What is going on?!”

The housemaster, a slim, middle-aged man, yelled sharply. That was when Lloyd straightened his back. He lifted his one hand and ran back his disheveled bang. Sweating and panting hard, Lloyd turned around and faced the housemaster.

“I was just defending my honor.”

“What is that?”

Flinch. The unexpected answer made the housemaster recoil. And when he finally saw the unconscious body of Diego sprawled on the ground, he bit his lips.

“Have you forgotten what place this is? You are in Magenta College, the academy run with the support of the great Queen. And yet, you stirred trouble, exercised violence, and hurt a student in this college,” accused the housemaster.

“So?”

“If you do not have any justifiable reason behind your violence, I shall have you in the hands of the guards and be severely punished.”

Murmur, murmur. By now, there were several groups of people behind the housemaster. Restaurant workers. Young students. College Administrators. Some were clicking their tongues, while some were condemning what just took place. Some were shocked, alternately looking at Diego and Lloyd. This was perhaps the reason why a bitter smile formed on Lloyd’s mouth.

They wouldn’t act like this if Julian was the one who got hurt. They probably wouldn’t have. They’d have turned a blind eye, thinking that it was not their business but the students’. No, they may have paid more attention to the voices of the bullies.

The bullies are from wealthy and powerful families, after all. That sort of unfair situation was highly likely. And so, Lloyds straightened his chest and scoffed, thinking about the plan he’d formed before wielding his punch at Diego.

“Justifiable reason, you say?” asked Lloyd.

“Do you have it?”

The housemaster’s gaze grew serious. Lloyd smirked.

“Yes, I do.”

“What is it?”

“Libel,” said Lloyd coolly.

“Excuse me?”

“This friend over here insulted me.”

“That’s it? That’s why you…”

“What do you mean by ‘that is it’? An insult to me is the same as insulting the queen.”

“What in the world are you saying now...?”

The housemaster’s eyes grew confused. He was left speechless, he couldn’t understand the nonsense Lloyd was spewing. And rightfully so.

Why on earth is he involving the queen in this? Especially when he’s nothing but a son of a rural provincial baron? His gaze toward Lloyd grew colder, and he couldn’t believe what he was hearing. Libel? Insult? The more he thought about it, the more laughable he thought Lloyd was. In fact, the housemaster was completely in the dark about what kind of exploit Lloyd had achieved back in Cremo. The news about it hadn’t spread in detail to the royal capital just yet. And so, the headmaster looked down on Lloyd due to his family status.

They said the visitor was Julian Frontera’s family, I believe? He was. The Frontera family. The baron over there didn’t slip a bribe or anything to him behind everyone’s back. He wondered if it was due to a lack of manners or common sense. How lowly the Frontera family was compared to Viscount Lacona, who secretly asked to give special attention to his son as he slipped a thick envelope of bills into the headmaster’s pocket. Thinking such, the housemaster resolved to himself that he would raise this issue and have the visitor pay for what he had done. That would be the only way for him to free himself from the reprimand of Viscount Lacona, who had bribed him.

“Clarify what your words and intentions were for speaking of the queen,” the housemaster said sternly with an equally stern gaze.

The people gathered behind him were shooting a similar gazes at Lloyd. Despite the fact that he was being showered with the look of rebuke, Lloyd remained calm and composed.

“Well, of course. The reason is simple,” Lloyd said and casually brought his hand into his pocket. And then, he brought out a round gold pendant and held it out for people to see.

“It’s because this is who I am.”

“Eeek!”

At that instant, the housemaster sucked in his breath. The eyes of the people behind him widened. Lloyd’s sneer grew wider as he saw how astonished they were over just a pendant.

“The queen has specially invited me and given me this token as her rightful honored guest. Since everyone here is studying or working at the college, I am sure that you will all recognize the meaning behind this item.”

“…”

Everyone’s gaze was fixed on the gold pendant in Lloyd’s hand. The eyes of the double-headed eagle imprinted at the center shone sharper and glinted against the sun. At the same time, they thought of one thing: That’s the seal of the honored guest of the queen. Replicating it was impossible in the first place, so there was nothing doubtful about its veracity.

Not a single response spilled out of people’s mouths. They were all clamped shut. The housemaster, who was now pale, chewed his lips. The cafeteria immediately grew silent just like that. When Lloyd spoke, his voice echoed through the air, and it thrashed like a whip against all the quiet listeners.

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Chapter 88: How To Eradicate Violence (3)

“I am sure you see the reason behind my actions and words now. That’s right. I am an honored guest who is currently staying at the palatial quarters after being summoned by Her Majesty. Therefore, any actions that insult me is the same as committing the grave sin of insulting Her Majesty.”

“...”

Lloyd’s clear voice echoed through the cafeteria. No one responded. No one could dare do it. As the silence continued to fill the room, he continued to speak.

“Moreover, I have heard of the beautiful story of how this academy is under the grace and support of the queen. And that makes all the students under the support of Her Majesty. And yet, it has never occurred to me that a student under Her Majesty’s auspices would dare insult her honored guest and regard her royal authority as nothing but trivial.”

A corner of Lloyd’s lips rolled upward. He shot a glance, daring the headmaster to give an answer.

The latter replied with a question, his shoulders drooping. “However, uhm, is it not your one-sided argument?”

“One-sided argument?”

“Is there any objective evidence that my student, Diego Lacona, has insulted you?”

“Evidence, you say? Hahaha,” Lloyd chuckled and shrugged his shoulders. And he added, “Certainly, there is. Don’t you know about the proof better than me?”

“Excuse me? What do you-”

“This boy right here, Julian Frontera.”

Thud. Lloyd held out his hand and placed it on Julian's small shoulder. This made Julian flinch, but Lloyd didn't mind. He nonchalantly had it remain there as he stared at the housemaster.

"I am telling you this just in case you might not know it, but this boy is my younger brother."

Julian flinched once again, and this time, the housemaster's eyes trembled for a second. Lloyd continued to speak.

"You insult him right in front of me, you insult me. You harass him, you insult me. As such, that is same as ruining the reputation of Her Majesty. If that is not showing any disregard for Her Majesty's authority, then what is?"

"How does that…"

"Are you trying to negate what I am saying?"

"..."

The housemaster clamped his mouth shut. Lloyd's acrid remarks continued.

"And I'm sure you are not telling me that you and the students behind you don't know what kind of relationship Diego and my brother has, right?"

"..."

Silence once again. No one could haphazardly throw a response at Lloyd, and it was obvious why. There was nothing secretive about Deigo harassing Julian on a daily basis. But it wasn't the affair relating only to Diego. All the other nobles of the high class did so as well. They all joined as one to ignore, discriminate, and insult Julian. A lot of students gathered behind the housemaster were Julian's harassers, who joked and made a bet among themselves on which method was the most innovative and novel way of making Julian's life miserable. Their rationale behind such abuse was that Julian was from a provincial baron family, and yet, he got praised multiple times by professors for his academic achievements. That is, everyone

bullied him because Julian acted without any knowledge of who he was. And so, Julian became the target for discrimination and scorn in the academy.

This is the reason why I'm doing this, you brat. Lloyd tightened the muscles in his arm, pressing down to stop Julian from removing his arm. Lloyd felt the glare Julian was shooting and understood the message he was sending. What's the deal with this ruckus? What's the point of this? Are you going to leave and have me deal with what comes after? Julian's resistant glare burned Lloyd's cheeks. But he ignored them all, for he was convinced that patience and endurance weren't the answer to responding to unfair discrimination and school violence.

Enduring it won't solve anything. It was true. He wasn't just saying his opinion. What he was doing was based on an actual and real-life event, the fluorescent light incident. He had learned his lesson there.

I got all scared after causing trouble the first time. But as time passed by, it wasn't the case. Things started to take off in an unexpected way. Right after Lloyd beat the daylights out of the bully with the fluorescent light and chair, the school was turned upside down in shock. Parents were summoned, the school violence committee opened up, and things began to develop unfavorably for Lloyd at first. It was understandable. After all, the only wrong the bully did was order Lloyd to get some bread and hit him a few times. But on the other hand, he struck back by sending the bully to the hospital. Thus, he got suspended, and he thought that was the end of things. However, it wasn't.

It turned out the bully had caused more than a little trouble before then. About three days after the incident, Lloyd received a call from a father of his classmate. And he explained that it seemed his son had been bullied by that jerk for a long time and seeing Lloyd fight back gave his son the courage to speak up about it for the first time. That was the beginning. Similar calls continued to pour in. The bully's dirty acts were made plain. Bags, clothes, hats, and shoes. Game consoles, cash, bicycle, cellphone, and laptop. They discovered one hundred dollars to two hundred dollars, and even up to thousands of dollars of money. As the evidence of his harassment was collected, the scale of his extortion proved to be larger than

everyone expected. Karma finally hit him well. The parents gathered to file a lawsuit against him, and he was thrown into juvenile court. Victims teamed up to internalize the message, “Karma’s a bi***, you jerk.”

And so, I need to go all out when responding to these things. If I’m going to do it, I need to do it right. Lloyd couldn’t just sit and trust the school to do the job. He needed to make sure that the law, police, and press sided with him. And to do that, he needed to make a large issue out of this incident. The larger the incident became, the better chances he had of winning. That was the plan he had in mind before taking action. He had beat the living soul out of Diego. It was time to crush school.

“So, housemaster, pray tell me. Are you still thinking that what I did is wrong?”

“...”

Lloyd cocked his head to the side. The housemaster began to get a headache. *This is troubling.* A crease was formed on the housemaster’s forehead. Of course, he, too, knew that Julian was a punching bag to the other students. He’d turned a blind eye and declared that it wasn’t his business. But he wasn’t particularly sorry about that. What was happening right now was tradition.

He’s nothing but a son of a provincial baron. Julian got scorned and mocked by the sons of upper class families in the capital because he was from the province. He was bound to intermittent disdain and physical abuse. The headmaster saw nothing wrong with it. After all, this was something that had taken place for decades in the academy. A natural occurrence. He didn’t even think about correcting this, and since it was a loss for him to cut ties with the sons of the powerful families, he didn’t want to meddle in this affair. His desire to stay out grew all the more when he thought about the flashy and powerful families that backed these students. Therefore, he turned a blind eye. Everything was fine until this moment. It wasn’t fine anymore. When the brother of the harassed student was an honored guest of the queen, the whole situation took on a whole different meaning.

“Take issue with it? I would never,” the housemaster uttered, his mouth forming a smile. He changed his attitude after quickly weighing things in his head.

“As you know, I am a person who is in charge of managing the dormitory. And so, it is my responsibility to verify the claims when an unfortunate event like this happens in the building.”

“So what are you trying to say?”

“Should you find yourself in a dispute in the future, please call for me instead of taking action by yourself,” the housemaster replied.

“Aha. You mean you’re going to provide me with a great service of reconciliation called mediation, yes?”

“I am glad that you know what I mean.”

The housemaster was experienced in his role and knew how to act at this dormitory that was filled with noble children. Seeing his face, Lloyd thought to himself...

What a snake. The housemaster skillfully yet subtly abandoned Diego and decided to befriend a new power. It seemed to Lloyd that the housemaster wanted to form a new connection from this incident. A snort escaped Lloyd, and the housemaster gave a proper bow before leaving. The students chattering among themselves scattered away, but Lloyd imprinted every single one of their faces in his memory until all were gone.

I’m going to get you all good. You wait and see. Lloyd internally made the resolve. He’d already intervened, and it was water under the bridge. If he stopped now, he’d be throwing his and his family’s reputation down the drain. And if this incident worked to form a bad public image of him to others, it’d hurt his business for a long time.

So I have to finish what I started. Suppressing the dark desire to have their heads on a platter, Lloyd said that he was done for now. Then, he turned and looked at Julian.

“I lost my appetite. Let’s go.”

“What?!”

Julian kept glaring at Lloyd and tried to free himself from Lloyd’s arm that wrapped around his shoulder. One of his eyebrows quirked up.

“Go? Where to?” huffed Julian.

“Just follow me.”

Lloyd then moved, keeping his arm on Julian’s shoulder. He then got out of the cafeteria, almost dragging Julian. They heard the murmuring noises from both sides, but Lloyd ignored every single one of them. He even ignored Julian fighting to free himself. Just like that, they strode across the corridor and headed to the opposite way of the lobby, where there was the office Lloyd had previously located a while ago. He figured it’d be like the administrative office in the school. Thinking such, he pushed the door open.

“I’m here for business.”

The water was already spilled. The people in the office widened their eyes as they gazed at Lloyd. They were too taken aback to ask what business he had here.

Lloyd said to one of the dazed clerks, “I’d like to file an leave of absence. The duration will be one year.”

His name is Julian Frontera. The shocking declaration caused Julian to go wide-eyed.

♣

“What are you doing?! Are you out of your mind?”

They were in front of the main gate of the academy in the cold winter. Julian’s shrill got raised by a pitch. How else would he react? He was struck dumb to the point of passing out.

“Who do you think you’re for causing all that mess back in there, huh? And who do you think you’re for filing a leave of absence against my will?!”

Huh? Julian recalled the event that happened a moment ago. Lloyd had barged into the office and filed for an LOA without so much as asking a question to him. There wasn’t any time to stop Lloyd. And so, he was forced to stop studying for a year in the academy.

This isn’t happening! Julian was livid. He couldn’t understand what Lloyd was doing. It was so thoughtless and irresponsible.

And he doesn't think at all! Julian jumped out of his skin when Lloyd suddenly began whacking Diego. A part of him did feel good because Diego constantly pestered him. The sight of him getting beaten up granted Julian an immense sense of pleasure, and when Lloyd brought out the pendant, Julian’s heart tingled in excitement.

But so what about it? What’s the point of this good feeling when it’s just temporary? Nothing. Meaningless. This good feeling was transient, and once Lloyd left the capital, Julian would have to bear the massive weight of the mess Lloyd had created alone. They would retaliate for sure, and the harassment would worsen by a few more degrees. Even if Lloyd had brought out the VIP seal, the reality he was in wouldn’t have changed by much.

They can always bully me in secret. From the point of the sons of noble families, they held bounty ways of secretly making a living hell out of someone. The mere thought of it brought chills to his spine, and Julian wasn’t confident he could endure it. Just when he thought things couldn’t get worse, Lloyd unilaterally filed for a leave of absence!

“Speak now. Are you telling me to run? Huh? You’re the one who messed up. Did you get me out of the academy because you know you can’t be responsible for what you did?! Is that it?!” bawled Julian.

He didn’t want that. Even when things became hellish, Julian wanted to stick around in the academy. He wanted to continue studying regardless of

the tribulations and frustrations. That was the only way he could help his family.

If I don't study, my family will be done for. That mindless brute will ruin everything for my family. Julian would have to spend his lifetime correcting what Lloyd had ruined. To do that, he needed to be educated and form connections, which he had already planned to do. But what? A leave of absence? Julian saw red at the decision. He felt it was a tyrannical act of trampling his determination. And so, maybe that was the reason why a wry smile formed on Lloyd's face.

"Ha! You think I'm doing this without any plans in mind?" asked Lloyd.

"What...?"

Duh! Julian wanted to shout that aloud. But Lloyd's declaration intercepted and pierced into Julian's ears first.

"First, I think we need to clarify your misunderstandings and go through some harsh training."

"What are you... Misunderstanding? And what? Training?"

"Yeah."

"What am I getting wrong?" asked Julian.

"Well, the first one is that I'm acting like a maverick. And second, you'll be able to handle Diego or any pricks by yourself once you get trained."

"..."

Julian felt the words stop in his throat, sensing that the way Lloyd stared at him was too serious. No playfulness or arrogance. That was a bit of a surprise for Julian since it was his first time seeing so. Maybe he was persuaded by Lloyd's gaze. Or maybe Julian was piqued by the possibility that he could deal with Diego by himself.

“Training...? What training? Where? Like sword fighting?” asked Julian, stuttering without his knowledge.

Lloyd scoffed and smiled. He then shared the secret that would toughen up Julian’s weak body and mind.

“What else is there? At the construction site. Shoveling.”

And just like that, Julian Frontera, the slim and frail child with beady eyes, became one of the laborers in the suspension bridge construction, which wasn’t part of his destiny.

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Chapter 89: Between Construction and Trust (1)

“So, the rumors are true?”

“Yes.”

“Are you sure it’s the truth and it’s not a misunderstanding or mistake?

“Yes, that’s right,” replied Javier.

“So, what you’re saying is, the story of how you stopped the Gigatitan from invading Cremo and how my brother finished it off is true without a tad bit of exaggeration?”

“Yes, of course.”

Julian gulped and stared at the man sitting across from the table. Javier’s handsomeness made the luxurious royal quarters look like an inn.

“Whew... I can believe this given that it’s coming from you,” confessed Julian.

“Then, did you not believe it before?” asked Javier.

“How could I?”

Julian couldn’t help but scoff at the ridiculousness of the whole thing. He shook his head before continuing to speak.

“Actually, I first heard of the news from a man from the palace. He advised that I should keep it only to myself since the details of the news weren’t made plain or something.”

“Is that so?”

“Yeah. He even told me that Her Majesty plans to summon Lloyd and you to reward you both and share the news with everyone. There was nothing else I was told.”

“What do you mean by nothing else?”

“You know, the details of how he caught the Gigatitan. They were untold.”

The edge of Julian’s round nose crinkled. Just then, his mind was interrupted by the visit of the palatial official.

“*Truly, what an excellent brother you have. I am envious.”*

Even now, Julian couldn’t forget the words the official spoke before leaving. Was it because he was honored and proud to have such a brother? Absolutely not.

“It was unbelievably dumbfounding,” Julian said.

“Think about it. They said he’s an excellent brother. Can you believe it?”

“Hmm...” Javier paused for a second.

“Did you suspect that the man was a con man pretending to be an official?”

“Of course, I did.”

“I am not surprised to hear that,” seconded Javier.

“Isn’t it obvious? A man suddenly appears out of nowhere and showers Lloyd with praise for his accomplishments and talent. I was skeptical at first. However, it turned out that he really was from the palace.”

“It must have been confusing.”

“Yeah.”

Julian nodded, and he continued to speak.

“So, I believed that there was some kind of misunderstanding. I mean, it’s Lloyd Frontera we are talking about. The very drunkard who never went a day without causing trouble.”

It was true. That was the Lloyd Julian remembered in his mind. Three years ago, Julian prepared to leave the Frontera fiefdom to enroll in the academy and wanted to greet his brother before leaving. After all, he was still brother, albeit how much Julian hated him. The moment he opened the door, the pungent and acrid smell of alcohol assaulted his nose, and then came a shout, yelling at him to get out since he's sleeping. Then, a bottle of alcohol was tossed in the air and hit the wall right beside Julian's face. The smell of liquor, the rough yelling, and the shattered bottle marked his last interaction with Lloyd three years before Julian left for school.

"So there."

Julian stroked the corner of his left eye by habit with his right hand. There was a small scar on his skin, a burrow that looked like a mole. He had gotten it from the shards of the glass bottle Lloyd threw three years ago.

"Honestly, I thought that an unknown hero was behind the achievement and some passersby saw Lloyd when in fact, he was just hovering around the area. I thought everyone had been mistaken."

"Did you think that Master Lloyd had taken credit from the real hero and pretended that it was his own doing?" clarified Javier.

"Yeah. Exactly," said Julian as he vigorously nodded.

"That was the only way I could accept the situation no matter how I thought about it. But who knew, the whole thing was true..."

Julian never thought that it could be true. A heavy sigh escaped him, and Javier smiled softly as he looked at his young master.

"I see. I understand what you are going through, Master Julian. I, too, went through the same thing."

"You too, Sir Asrahan?"

"Yes."

Javier nodded.

“It just happened out of the blue. There were no impending signs or clues. It was just like any other day. The morning after a night of drunken ruckus in the bar.”

“Did something happen that day?” asked Julian curiously.

“Yes, Master Lloyd became different.”

“Different? What do you mean?” Julian spoke, raising one of his brows.

“As I said, he became different. As if someone else’s soul entered his body.”

The furnace filled the room with warmth, and it was tightly enclosed so that not a whiff of cold wind blew into the cozy space. Javier’s steadfast voice was the only thing filling the room.

“He became hardworking, considerate of others, and sober.”

“What...? No way...”

“It is true. Not only did he stop drinking, but he also began to work on all sorts of construction projects I never imagined was even possible.”

“Just like the artificial ground Lloyd had built after being commissioned by Count Cremo?” asked Julian.

“Yes,” Javier answered and continued to explain.

“He achieved more things outside of that as well. It’s the ultimate result of his dutifulness, brightness, pettiness, and shrewdness.”

“Petty and shrewd?”

“The qualities he never had but now owns.”

Javier furrowed his brows before speaking again.

“They are traits he didn’t possess as a troubling drunkard. When he changed, however, he grew petty, never letting himself be in the position of

loss, no matter how small. Let’s just say that, even if he was in the middle of a meal, he would drop everything to get his money back if he realized the construction payment, he received was off by a mere cent.”

“Woah...” gasped Julian.

“On top of that, he is shrewd. He takes advantage of any weakness you have, no matter how trivial. He has you in his grasp and shakes you up. There is just no way to fight back. Not only that, but he also doesn’t even try to hide his joy at seeing you suffer. He has a nasty temperament.”

“It sounds like he’s gotten worse,” Julian pointed out.

“Indeed. Oh, there’s one more thing.”

“What is it?”

“It seems that he has gotten more confident about his appearance.”

“What? Lloyd?” Julian shrilled.

“Yes.”

“Impossible.”

“It is the truth. Sometimes, he burns with competitiveness when he looks at me.”

“Tsk, tsk. He lost touch with reality.”

Now, pity filled Julian’s eyes.

“I thought the same.”

“Mhm. He should know his place.”

“That is right. At least before he changed, the young master held a clear grasp of where he stood in terms of appearance. I wonder how he turned out

this way. Sometimes, he explicitly shows his envy and anger when I tell him the number of love letters I'd received."

"How unfortunate. That's pitiful of him," Julian said with a sigh.

"I couldn't agree with you more."

Julian Frontera, the second son of the baron and Javier Asrahan, the faithful knight of the barony, caught up with one another after three years, seeing eye to eye on strange topics. However, they were ignorant of the fact that Lloyd was just beside the room, working on his design. Lloyd clenched his teeth.

"I can hear you loud and clear, you bastards..."

Lloyd sighed at length as the whispers from the gossiping traitors in the other room pierced into his ears. He wondered how he ended up with such a brother and personal knight. Contrary to his sigh, the corners of his mouth were curved into a smile. It was because of the message that floated in front of his eyes.

[Your likeability with Julian Frontera has increased by two points.]

[Current RP with Julian Frontera: -fifty-nine]

[You have earned twenty-eight RP by slightly improving your relationship with the main character.]

[Current RP: 2,164]

[Your intimacy level with Julian Frontera has upgraded from <Extreme Hatred> to <Hatred>.]

[You have earned five RP as a bonus for the improvement.]

[Current RP: 2,169]

Yes. Good.

The notification message for the increase in RP was always welcomed. It never got old no matter the time, day, or how often it came. This message felt more meaningful to him than usual.

This means that I now have a new source of RP.

Indeed, Julian was the new source of his RP, and it had been quite a while since he found one.

I don't earn RP just for getting close with someone. I know for sure based on what I observed up to this point.

At first, he thought that he could earn RP from others just by being friends with them. But that wasn't the case. The best example was Count Cremo.

No matter how close I got with him or what favors I did for him, the message of likeability didn't pop up.

It wasn't like Count Cremo held antagonistic feelings toward Lloyd. It was the opposite. He expressed insurmountable fondness for Lloyd to the point that he asked him to be his son-in-law. However, not a single message popped in front of his eyes regarding the count. There was no notification for an increase of RP or likeability level. That was why he concluded to himself...

Everyone who gives me RP must have something in common. There must be certain requirements that need to be met for the likeability system to get activated.

Lloyd had formed a rough theory in his head, and now, he found the answer.

They must be a person within my reach. That's the right answer.

He could almost ascertain that it was true as he read through the messages about Julian and as he recalled the events with the orcs.

So far, the people who gave me RP mostly belonged to the barony. The baron couple, Javier, Sir Bayern, the residents, and the orc tribe members, formed the blood alliance with us.

Therefore, the RP system was only activated when the person was a member of his barony or an official ally. Lloyd became almost sure about it. Now, as he looked at Julian, he started to see his younger brother differently.

My dear brother. Congratulations on hopping onto Lloyd's emotional rollercoaster.

A large grin formed on his face, revealing all his teeth, when he thought of taking advantage of Julian and sucking the RP out of him. At the same time, he thought of what was ahead of him.

Since I brought him here, I should be responsible for him.

Lloyd had filed for an LOA and brought Julian here to the palatial quarters. However, he knew that it didn't truly resolve the bullying Julian went through in school.

The boy needs to get stronger in both mind and body.

Nobody harassed the strong, and when strength was joined by endurance, that was the icing on the cake. The fundamental solution Lloyd came up with was that. It could appear dirty and unfair, but the uncomfortable truth could not be denied even if one wished to go against it.

Sure, there are rules and systems in place to prevent such a mishap, but those could only lessen the unreasonable and unfair sides of things. They never act as a protector.

The housemaster of Julian's boarding school came to Lloyd's mind, as well as the workers. Everyone chose to be silent and overlook the situation. They turned a blind eye to Julian, and this served as the best example of how powerless and ineffective the rules and systems could be at times.

So even if it means getting harsh on him, I need to train him.

Surely, Julian wasn't Lloyd's brother by blood, and he never had a brother in his life back in Korea as well. What was more, it had been only half a

day since he met Julian. However, the RP system and its messages illustrated something very clearly to Lloyd.

That boy has become a member of my inner circle. I'm responsible for anyone who belongs to it. This principle must be upheld so that those who are in it will feel it in their bones.

That was how he would be able to expand his influence and keep them by his side. *That's how I'll get more RP.*

Reminding himself of that fact, he started to plan out his future and shifted his focus back to the suspension bridge design and simulation mode. The other side of the wall continued to bring the soft and happy voices of Julian, Javier, Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang into his room. Among them, Julian's voice contained the biggest joy. The relief and comfort must have been overwhelming for him to be surrounded by his friends rather than harassment and discrimination. Each time he spoke, Lloyd sensed something warm in his voice. That was when it occurred to Lloyd that he had made the right choice to get Julian out of the boarding school. I should be nicer to him, Lloyd thought to himself. Just like that, the night filled with zealous designing and cozy conversations passed.

* * *

The following morning rolled around. Lloyd became busy. He bolted out of his quarters the moment he woke up, and he was heading to the forge in the palace, holding dozens of blueprints in his arms. It was the blueprints he had printed out using his optional skill late in the night.

"I wish to meet the supervisor here."

When Lloyd expressed that he was the builder for the construction Her Majesty had commissioned, the supervisor came out to meet him.

"What brings you here?"

The man was about four feet in height, and his body was shaped like a barrel. His shoulders were extremely wide, and the beard that hung down

his face reminded Lloyd of Santa Claus. With wrinkled eyes that made him look as obstinate as a mule, the old man looked up at Lloyd.

So, this is what dwarves look like.

It was the first time Lloyd met a dwarf. He had only read about them in novels before then. However, he quickly pushed aside his fascination with the exotic being. Instead, he put on a salesman's smile and began to talk.

“Hello. My name is Lloyd Frontera. I am here to ask you to manufacture some things that are needed for a construction project ordered by Her Majesty.”

“You want me to manufacture something for you?”

“Yes, that’s right.”

“What kind of fancy items do you plan on building? We are highly selective in taking the jobs. What’s more, you want items for the construction, not weapons nor armor. Why don’t you tap other forges for that?”

“If any other forges could do what I want, I wouldn’t be here in the first place,” explained Lloyd.

“Hmm... So, are you saying this is your only option?”

“Yes.”

“What an honest sycophant you are,” replied the dwarf.

“I would like to believe that I’m an honest man.”

Lloyd grinned. Just then, he recalled *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* The dwarf in front of him was the supervisor of the forge in the royal palace. He was rumored to be an unrivaled blacksmith and could produce anything with his hands if they were metal. As such, the dwarf’s help was indispensable to Lloyd for this task.

No other dwarf will do.

The item Lloyd wanted him to build would bear the massive weight of the suspension bridge. So, only the best and superior sturdiness and quality could be trusted. He needed that master craftsman to do the job. The problem was that the dwarf didn't hold his hammer unless a job piqued his interest. If not, he would relegate the jobs to the masters below him.

He's notorious for taking only what interests him, even if the order comes from Her Majesty.

So, it was imperative for Lloyd to earn his attention. He must make the master dwarf to want to build it. Reminding him that in his head a few times, Lloyd looked around and found a clean working table. He walked over to the dwarf's direction and spread out the blueprint.

"Here, first take a look at this."

Lloyd confidently spread out his blueprint, and the dwarf's gaze traveled across the width of it.

Is that...?

Wels Corgidus, the supervisor of the royal forge and the master craftsman. He quirked his brows. Lloyd's meaningful words pierced into his ears like a jab.

"Have you ever heard of a sky bridge?"

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Chapter 90: Between Construction and Trust (2)

Wels Corgidus, the master craftsman, and the man in charge of the royal forge, visibly quirked his eyebrows.

“This is... Hmm... Are they the frames to support the weight?”

His tenacious eyes, which were distinct features to dwarfs, scanned the blueprint that contained a frame he had never seen before. *Looks like a frame.* There were straight bars connected to each other, intricately forming triangular shapes. Overall, dozens of short bars laid slanted and formed triangles in the area between two straight elongated bars. Corgidus, like the master of craft he was, immediately identified the purpose of the structure in the blueprint, as well as the flow of force on the structure and the balance of weight the structure would withstand.

“Is this going to be used in the bridge?” asked Corgidus.

“Yes, you are right. It’s called a truss.”

Lloyd smiled, impressed. Corgidus was just as the novel had described him. Corgidus tossed another question to Lloyd.

“Surely, this design would allow the wide structure to carry the most weight possible. But who designed this? Tell me, do you also have a dwarf master craftsman working for you?”

“No,” replied Lloyd.

“If not, who did it?”

“I did.”

“What?” The dwarf’s brow twitched.

“I designed this one. I did.”

A mysterious light flashed across Corgidus’s eyes as he looked up at Lloyd. He blurted out something not very nice.

“My, you are one heck of a nutcase.”

“Haha. Is that so?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, indeed. You came to threaten me, right?”

“Did you already notice...?”

“Of course.”

Corgidus heavily exhaled through his nose.

“A mediocre blacksmith could never create something like this. No, in this forge as well, there wouldn’t be anyone else but me who can produce this. After all, it involves producing the entire metal structure with an equal distribution of weight and entrusting the job to other master craftsmen...”

That would lead to a disastrous accident. Corgidus was sure of it. It would be even so for a truss structure that appeared to be fine on the outside. One clumsy mistake during production would create an imbalanced distribution of weight on the inside. What would happen if one built a bridge on top of it?

“It will collapse. That’s the thing with metals. It looks fine until it suddenly snaps. That’s what is so scary.”

What would happen if the truss snapped, and the bridge collapsed? It would spell a disastrous accident where at least dozens would perish.

“Yet, you came to me and showed me the blueprint of such a structure? What, you thought I wouldn’t be able to see through you?”

“Actually, I wanted you to see me through like now,” Lloyd replied nonchalantly after chuckling. Corgidus clicked his tongue.

“Are you testing my conscience?”

“Well, you can always say no if you don’t want to.”

“So, you want me to watch the accident in the future and feel guilty?”

“The choice is yours,” said Lloyd, “so I will not force it upon you.”

“Are you not confident that you can pique my interest and get me to accept the order?”

“Indeed. I’m not confident at all. How can I when I am nothing? So that’s why I did it.”

“Did what?” asked Corgidus.

“I’d thought that I stand a greater chance by appealing to your conscience this way.”

“And why are you coming clean about it?”

“Because you’ll know even if I hide it.”

“Hahaha.”

Corgidus guffawed, and his thick beard danced along with his head. He considered Lloyd brazen. However, he didn’t hate him for it because such an attitude came rare among his visitors.

Usually, they try to abuse their position or provoke and test my skills.

But Lloyd, the boy that showed up in front of him, was slightly different. He was crystal clear about what he wanted. He didn’t parade around his position or attempt obvious provocations to challenge him. He only emphasized the truth that Corgidus was needed to make his construction project safe and successful. At last, after mulling over the matter, Corgidus made a decision.

“Let’s see your other blueprints.”

“That means...”

“Give me the blueprints first,” demanded Corgidus.

“Yes.”

Lloyd busied himself, spreading the blueprints in order. Each time it spread out; a pleasant shock was sent to the dwarf’s eyes to his relief. The large socket to fix the bridge cables to the bridge towers. The link-type joint connecting device to respond to the elasticity depending on the temperature change of the bridge. The flap to reduce the vibration level in the bridge depending on the wind level. Countless modules and components spanned in front of his eyes. A sense of responsibility suddenly surged in him, his eyes brimming with determination. And at last, he nodded.

“Okay,” Corgidus finally said, “Let’s do it. We’re doing it.”

“Do you really mean it?”

“Do I look like I’m lying?” Corgidus’s meticulous eyes stared at Lloyd’s face.

“I became more certain when I scanned the other blueprints you showed me. There’s only one being who can create this structure in the whole kingdom. Goodness, and if you have someone else build this, only for it to collapse later, my conscience will be bothered. This job isn’t a matter of interest. It’s about what is right.”

“Thank you,” replied Lloyd.

“You can save your gratitude. You owe me a lot of explanation as I’ll be making them for the first time. Don’t even think about going back home today.”

“I wasn’t planning to in the first place.”

Lloyd spoke, grinned, and opened his bag, which contained stacks of lunch boxes he had prepared. Moreover, it was for two people.

“Hahaha.”

Could it be that he saw this coming when he got here?

Corgidus once again felt that this boy over here wasn't a normal brat. Now, the gaze Corgidus sent to Lloyd was no longer that of interest. It was satisfaction.

* * *

Three days passed, and Lloyd was not allowed to leave the royal forge during that period. Corgidus turned out to be a meticulous and detailed craftsman, befitting his status as a master. He asked questions, even Lloyd missed, about the details and directions of the production. Lloyd even broke out into sweat a few times trying to explain certain things to Corgidus.

He's a master for a reason.

In fact, Lloyd received help from the design skill when he came up with the blueprint. So, a few of the details were missed and overlooked in the process. But now that he was hearing questions from the master of the craft, who was on par with his university professors, Lloyd realized that he was not paying attention to the details.

From now on, I should start designing with a fine-tooth comb.

Three days later, Lloyd was permitted to leave the forge. That didn't mean the end of his job. Instead, it was time for him to really get serious.

"All right, let's do some cooking, shall we?"

Lloyd cracked his knuckles as he looked straight ahead. He was now in a small training hall the palace loaned him to use, and a huge pile of sand sat there. The sand was the main ingredient for today's cooking.

Everything was delivered just as I asked. I expected nothing less from the palace.

Oil-mixed clay, stone powder clay, magnetite, pebbles, grinded basalt, obsidian, azure stone, talcum, and tin were there. Each ingredient was placed in separate piles.

I’ll go first with the oil-mixed clay.

Lloyd’s shoveling began. He first scooped the oil-mixed clay and pressed it flat with his shovel, making it into the shape of a pizza dough that was about thirty feet in diameter. He then sprinkled all sorts of sand on top, which he finished with stones like basalt, obsidian, and others. Once he was done, Lloyd served it to Bangul, who was waiting with a growling stomach.

“Bangul,” Lloyd called.

“Bangul!”

“I made it just the way you wanted.”

“Bba-bangul!”

“Want to try eating this?”

“Bangul!”

Bangul turned gigantic and took a large bite of the sand pizza, chewing several times before gulping it down. At last, she wagged her tail hard.

The bell attached to her tail rattled violently, and she lifted her fat tail high up and shouted, “Bangul!”

Lloyd moved instantly at the noise and threw the granite tray he had prepared before her buttock. Metal bars that were thinner than usual started to come out of her buttocks. Red and hot metal bars stacked itself onto the granite tray, and Lloyd twirled the tray just in time to make sure that the bars would coil around the tray.

“Fan them!” Lloyd shouted.

As soon as he yelled, a gush of wind blew from both sides, which was the work of Javier and Julian standing by Lloyd. They wielded the fans very passionately.

The violent wind cooled the bars in no time. After all, the diameter of the bars was only about 0.2 inches thick. They were more like metal wires rather than bars.

Good. They turned out just fine on the outside.

Lloyd's eyes held a joyful smile. Bangul had been honest about excreting thin metal wires if she ate according to the recipe. True to her words, the granite tray carried an abundant load of wires.

Let's check if they function just as well as they look.

The wire would be used to support the suspension bridge, so it was imperative for Lloyd to test out how durable it was.

The load cell machine sounds like a perfect thing to have to test its applied force.

To his regret, there was no way he could get his hands on such a modern machine. Thus, he tested the tension of the wires by himself.

"Javier," Lloyd called.

"Yes."

"Hold this."

Lloyd held out the cooled wire and told him to grip one end. Then, he grabbed the other end.

"Now, I'm going to pull this hard, and you have to hold on without swaying."

"Yes, Young Master."

"You can't pull it either. Even a little."

"I just need to hold and endure?"

“Yes. This is to test how much force the wire can withstand.”

The exact math became complicated once Javier’s pulling force was added in the equation. So, Javier had to remain at a fixed position. Lloyd’s pulling force was the only input needed in this test.

“Here we go.”

Lloyd gripped the wire and employed one mana circle. He even used an optional skill to accurately measure the force.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option four: Circle Shift has been activated.]

Since I need to test by stage, I’ll start with the low gear. He set the gear to level one. The circle reacted instantly.

[The Alpha circle is set to gear one. Fixed at RPM 1,000.]

The RPM of the first circle was set to 1,000, and he transferred the amplified power of mana into his right arm. He then yanked the wire.

The wire stretched tightly, but it didn’t snap. It held very well. *Time for gear two.*

[The Alpha circle is set to gear two. Fixed at RPM 2,000.]

Lloyd tugged the taut wire with more force. It didn’t snap this time, either. He revved up his gear to three and four... until five. That’s when it snapped off.

Good. Somewhere between gear four and five based on the single circle. One more time.

The test continued. He first used the optional skill Circle Shift and set the stable RPM. Later, he turned off the skill and employed a more detailed RPM. Thanks to that, Lloyd was able to identify the tension of the wires Bangul produced.

The wire roughly snaps in between 4,600 and 4,700 RPM. Computing this to force... Hmm... It looks okay.

This was more than okay as it didn’t fall short of the wires used in modern times in South Korea. Now, it was time to produce the cables. Lloyd dug his hand into the inner pocket and brought out a summon creature taking a sweet nap in there.

“Hey, Ppodong.”

“Ppodong...”

“I’m sorry to wake you up, but can you do me a favor, please?”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“From now on, Bangul will be making some wires for you.”

“Ppodong?”

“Once they cool, can you cluster them together and roll them up? Roll about 120 strands into one, like a bunch of dried noodles you would see in markets.”

Lloyd picked up a twig and drew something on the ground to help Ppodong understand better.

“What do you think? Do you think you can do it?”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong nodded confidently. He liked doing favors for Lloyd. A smile of satisfaction hung on Lloyd’s smile.

“Yes, thank you. First, eat this one.”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong grew thirty feet after eating the red sunflower seed. From then on, Ppodong rubbed his hands zealously, and Bangul got ready to excrete metal wires and shook her buttock.

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!”

“Bba-bangul! Bangul!”

Now that it was ready to produce cables, Lloyd turned around and stared at the third worker he had appointed at the back of his mind.

“Hey,” Lloyd called.

“Eh? What?”

Julian flinched when he was called. He was in a daze. It was his first time seeing the giant summon creatures, and Lloyd was freely controlling them. The corners of Lloyd’s lips rolled upward.

“I’ll be working on the basic construction of the bridge towers with Javier.”

“Oh, sure,” Julian said.

“So, we need to vacate this place.”

“Yeah, so?”

“I want you to hold down the fort for me.”

“Me? How?” Julian asked curiously.

“How else?”

Lloyd lifted his shovel and held it out to Julian.

“Here.”

Before he had any time to resist, Julian found himself carrying a large shovel in his small arms.

“Imagine you’re with your friends, grilling some delicious and juicy meat, but you ran out of cooked meat, and the ones on the grill aren’t ready yet. So, you are now forced to wait until the new meat is done. You stopped eating in the middle of a tasty meal. How do you think you’d feel?”

“Uh, I guess I’ll get anxious and annoyed.”

“Right? I knew you’d understand. Therefore...”

Lloyd’s smile turned suggestive.

“You should start shoveling, and make sure to be faster than the speed of Bangul eating her sand. The recipe needs to be followed as closely as possible. Okay?”

“The sand you dig up with your shovel will be transformed into wires through Bangul, which will in turn become the cables that support the entire suspension bridge. So, do you see where I’m getting at? Put all your effort into it”

Julian’s adam’s apple fluctuated as he swallowed drily. The young master had done nothing but study until now. He didn’t understand the importance of shoveling until Lloyd enlightened him with the sheer purpose behind such a seemingly simple act.

“Hold on, wait,” Julian hurriedly stopped Lloyd as the latter was leaving.

“Wait, then, isn’t this super important?” asked Julian in disbelief.

“You’re right.”

“Then you’re entrusting it to me? Why?”

Julian was curious. Something was off. This person in front of him was Lloyd Frontera, the object of his unchanging hatred and doubt. It was the same case for Lloyd as well. He never believed in Julian. Each time Lloyd requested to go drinking and got rejected, he hurled curse words at Julian in anger and dismissed him as nothing but a buzzkill. As such, it was a wonder

why Lloyd gazed at him with such seriousness while speaking in a gentle voice as if he always did.

“I’m entrusting it to you because it’s important.”

Though Julian wasn’t aware of it, his eyes trembled visibly.

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Chapter 91: Sky-Walking Bridge (1)

“I’m entrusting it to you because it’s important.”

“Huh?”

Julian’s eyes trembled visibly. He couldn’t believe it. Entrusting it to him because it’s important? Julian wondered if he was serious. And besides... *Seriously, is this Lloyd Frontera?*

Not once in his life did, he expect to hear such a thing from his brother. If someone had prophesied about this in his dream, he’d have laughed out loud at the prophecy. However, that very impossible event was happening now right in front of his eyes, so clear and vivid that it was undeniable.

Entrust it to me because it’s important? He gawked at the shovel in his hands, and though he was a bit numb, it didn’t feel unpleasant. Just then, he was hit with an important fact. That was...

“Uhm, how do you use this shovel?” asked Julian.

“How, my ass. Have you never used a shovel before?”

“Uhm, no, never.”

Julian nodded because he had never used this tool before. He was unsure whether he could take up such an important job. *Lloyd will probably be disappointed. He’s going to scold and downplay me for not having done this before.* Julian was ready to receive such. And just as he had expected...

“Tsk. Whatever, give it to me,” Lloyd said as he held out his hand.

Of course.

Julian, a little bit disappointed, gave the shovel back to Lloyd. Instead of ignoring or criticizing Julian, Lloyd instead rolled up his sleeves and stretched his shoulders.

“I’m going to show it to you once. Watch me.”

“Eh...? Okay...”

“Watch how I do it.”

Lloyd didn’t wait for a response. He was already posing in front of the piles of sand. His lower torso and waist were slightly drooped, and the back of his left hand faced the sky.

“Take a look at my left hand. This is how you grab it. Don’t stab the ground, dig into it, and scoop up the sand. See this?”

“Oh, yeah,” Julian said.

“From here to the left rear. Like this!”

The shovel drew a soft trajectory in the air after scooping. It then returned to the sand pile at lightning speed. Lloyd dug in the sand, scooped it, moved it, sprinkled it on the ground, and stacked it up.

“Got that?”

In no time, Lloyd was holding the shovel like it was a cane. Lloyd smiled, and in Julian’s eyes, he looked like a seasoned master of labor. Julian found himself nodding at the sight in front of him.

“Eh? Okay.”

“Good,” said Lloyd, “Do what you just saw.”

“Okay.”

“But make sure that you straighten your back only when you’ve filled up the one-legged cart to the brim. Am I clear?”

“Why is that?” asked Julian.

“That’s how I do things.”

“Anyway, do a good job. The speed of Bangul making wires depends on how fast you shovel. I’m off now,” Lloyd said as he passed the shovel.

Julian took it, and he could feel the warmth in the hilt and handle. The moment Julian touched it, he suddenly wanted to know. Why didn’t Lloyd ignore or mock him when he said that he wasn’t good at shoveling? Why did Lloyd teach him so nicely instead? And...

“Uhm, Lloyd.”

“What?”

“I have something to ask you.”

Julian lifted his head, and he got ready to say the question he had all along.

“Where did you learn all this, Lloyd?”

Julian wanted to know. It was strange. He wanted to ask what Lloyd went through all this time. *It’s as if he has become a different person.* Lloyd Frontera was standing in front of him, but he seemed poles apart from the man he knew. He was sober and gentle. The two changes were enough to give him goosebumps.

“I’m curious. You didn’t know how to use the shovel before.”

“That’s right.”

“The same goes for the summon magic. I heard you called for the summon creatures.”

“Yes, I did.”

“And Sir Asrahan told me that you have a manaheart.”

“You’re right.”

“What in the world happened to you back when I was in the academy?”

Something happened. Otherwise, this would be impossible. But the response Lloyd gave only plunged him into deeper confusion.

“Something happened... I’ll tell you next time.”

“When?”

“When I’m ready.”

Lloyd smiled bitterly, and his eyes seemed to hold a backstory, which made him look inexplicably alienating and mesmerizing. So, Julian couldn’t probe any longer. He eventually thought to himself that the time would come when Lloyd would tell him everything. At last, Julian nodded, much to Lloyd’s relief.

Whew. It worked.

His operation to dodge Julian's probing questions was a success. After duping his brother with his masked seriousness, Lloyd hurried and left the area, saying that he needed to look at the field quickly. Now, left alone, Julian picked up the shovel.

“Whew.”

The shovel felt heavy in his hands. Nonetheless, he decided to try his best. He just earned Lloyd’s trust, which came rare. To be honest, it weirded Julian out a bit but not in a bad way. He was rather happy. He even resolved not to disappoint his brother. Recalling how Lloyd had gripped the shovel, Julian grabbed it and moved. He stabbed the sand pile with a shovel, but the result was terribly different from Lloyd’s.

The shovel made a weird noise as it hit the sand. It failed to dig deep into the earth. Instead, it slipped to the side and left his hands.

The shovel bounced in the air and was sent away so that it shamed Julian. Bangul, who was watching the scene, tapped the ground with her fat tail. Ppoddong joined, writhing his fat body in amusement, and forgetting to interlace the strands of wire.

“Bangul! Bba-ba-babangul!”

“Ppodong! Ppo-do-do-dong!”

Are they laughing at me...?

Heat rushed through Julian’s face as he sprinted to pick up the shovel again. He was a red tomato. This was just the start of the many challenges ahead of the short young master.

* * *

The construction took off with full force. The survey and design were already over. The trusses and cables were being produced without any hurdles. So, Lloyd proceeded to work on building the bridge towers of the suspension bridge. The first step was constructing the base.

Lloyd’s triple circle rotated violently. two: three: three. With the Alpha circle at the center, the other two rotated in a ratio of two: three: three. They clashed and bumped into each other, backed by the ideal rotation ratio. At that instant, Lloyd dug the shovel into the ground, transferring the power of the triple mana blast into the land.

Lloyd bore holes into the ground that were about sixty feet in diameter and 114 feet deep with terrible force, not missing a fraction of an inch. He dug one hole per day for a total of nine holes on each side of the riverside. Those holes would support the bridge towers of the suspension bridge. Next, Lloyd poured a large amount of cement into the holes. The cement, which was mixed with the volcanic ash of Bangul, filled them up just like how Lloyd did when he built the artificial ground in the water in Cremo. They solidified, turning into huge cement poles that stretched down to the underground.

The spring rain came right after the basic construction was finished. It was torrential spring rain. Heavy rain kept coming for over ten days, quickly increasing the water level of the Magena River. Eventually, that created cracks in the stone bridge that sat about one hundred yards off the

suspension bridge. It was the first time it had happened since sixty-one years ago when it was first built. Lloyd smiled internally.

Even heaven is helping with this project.

The stone bridge showed signs of collapse, and that prompted the palace to change its stance on the project. The officials started to shower him with support in building the suspension bridge instead of spending the resources on repairing the damaged stone bridge. They heavily invested in the construction, starting from employing more laborers for the project. Expert craftsmen and skillful men joined the force, and the support of the palatial magicians just topped everything off.

Thank you! Thank you so much!

Once the magicians joined the construction efforts, everything started to quickly progress at an unbelievable speed. Lloyd's design, which was supported by his surveying and data, was as detailed and comprehensive as a microscope. When that was compounded together with the palace's unreserved monetary support and labor, the construction took off at lightning speed.

This is nuts. This is absolutely nuts!

Lloyd clucked his tongue in disbelief as he commanded the construction. The tower was mainly composed of stones, and Lloyd simply needed to let them know the size to cut out. Once the shape and function of the blocks were made plain to the expert stonemasons, they jumped into action. Magicians joined as well. As such, the job ended in no time. The same went for stacking the blocks to make the tower. Normally, Lloyd required a crane or Ppodong to lift the massive blocks, and it was a challenge to stack up more than ten blocks a day. But when magicians came into the picture, everything changed. They were not your average magicians. They were royal magicians.

Magicians imbibed magic into the large blocks and reduced them to one-fifth of their giant size. That alone completely changed the construction speed.

“Pull! Count during the process!”

“One! Two! One!”

Large blocks hoisted up each time dozens of people turned the lever of the crane. The downsized blocks took a lesser toll on Javier and Ppodong, who received the blocks. Magicians used magic to lift them up, while those above received the blocks without any concern of spraining their backs. Every task proceeded like an impeccable cogwheel, and it was obvious that Lloyd’s meticulous design work was behind it. Just like that, time continued to pass.

The wind grew warmer. Magnolia flowers blossomed and wilted. The cherry blossom leaves wafted in the air against the wind. The aroma of roses permeated the air every morning. Julian’s arms thickened from all the shoveling. On the day the cicadas started singing, 295-foot bridge towers stood tall on both sides of the Magena River. Citizens in the royal capital exclaimed in joy because they had been nervous about the existing stone bridge, which could collapse anytime. But now, the construction for a new bridge was nearing its completion. The unique shape of the suspension bridge garnered much attention from people.

“What do you think he plans to do by setting up the tower so high?”

“Did you not hear?”

“Excuse me? Hear what?”

“He’s said to plan hanging cables at the peak of the towers.”

“Cables, you say?”

“Yes, indeed. Just like a hanging clothesline.”

“What kind of...”

Some citizens tilted their heads as they chatted, while others were expectant.

“Did you hear? He’s planning to hang a clothesline there.”

“Clothesline? Wait, in between the towers on both sides of the river?”

“Yes, I heard from the lady beside the house. The hanging clotheslines will become bridges.”

“Come on, how’s that possible?”

“I’m telling you. The cable work is happening later in the afternoon.”

“Really?”

“Yes, I’m telling you. I reserved a spot to watch it for myself.”

“Can I tag along?”

“Of course.”

People gathered near the river in groups of threes and fives. They set up mats where they could get a good look at the towers. Lunch boxes were open. When they laid their eyes on the cables being delivered under the bridge towers, they were overwhelmed with shock.

“What... is that?”

“Good gracious. They’re very thick.”

“Clothesline? That’s a clothesline?”

“Oh, who said it’s one?”

“They’re thicker than tree stomps.”

“Plus, that’s not hay or anything. It’s made from metal.”

It was true. The cable was pure metal. Ppodong interlaced the 0.2-inch-thick wires Ppodong had excreted. Those 120 strands of wires tightly clustered together to form a cable. Then the outside was wrapped with chains. So, it

was too heavy and thick to be called a simple “clothesline.” When people saw the cable, everyone became nervous, thinking of one thing.

How is he going to transfer that to the peak of the bridge towers? Is he going to bring a large giant to toss and receive the cables? Is he going to use ships? There are no sailing boats around here in the river, and it might even sink if it’s small.

Curiosity filled everyone’s minds, and they all became worried about how the large and thick metallic ropes would be hung on the bridge towers like a clothesline. No matter how they thought about it, it looked impossible. The mere act of trying looked like an accident waiting to happen. Thousands of anxious and expectant gazes focused on the peak of the bridge towers, where Lloyd and Bangul were.

“Bangul, you know what to do, right?”

“Bangul!”

“You bite it and go boom!”

“Bba-bangul!”

Bangul, who had already gotten large, nodded her round head up and down. At last, Lloyd noticed the cable being lifted from the foot of the tower. It was being lifted by the crane after growing light with the help of the magicians’ magic. Its end was attached to a tightly knit chain, which Lloyd tugged and put on one side. Afterward, he held up the sand-filled bucket.

“Hey, Bangul. Time to eat something good.”

“Bangul!”

Bangul opened her mouth wide, and Lloyd emptied the whole bucket by pouring the sand into her mouth. He quickly stepped back.

“So, Bangul. Just as we practiced,” reminded Lloyd.

“Chomp, chomp! Bangul!”

Bangul gulped the sand, and she turned her round head to bite the chain that was set aside on one side. Then, she coiled her body. A chemical reaction took place inside her body. The food she consumed in one go digested in her body at a fast speed.

“Bungul! Bbu-bungul!”

*J*Bangul wagged her fat tail, and the clear ringing sound of the bell drummed in everyone’s ears. Next, a fierce volcanic explosion took place in Bangul’s buttocks.

The volcanic ash and gas emitted out of her body with such ferocity. The repulsive force sent Bangul to fly away into the air, and she bit on the chain with her mouth. And as she traveled airborne, the cable attached to the chain followed suit.

“Buuuung-ul!”

That day, the people’s jaws dropped as they saw a giant snake with a cable in its mouth travel across the Magena River, just like an arrow fixed to a rope.

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Chapter 92: Sky-Walking Bridge (2)

“Buuuung-ul!”

Once the volcanic skill activated, the magma built inside Bangul’s stomach crushed into a million pieces and gushed out in a ferocious manner. The sixteen-foot fat body was propelled forward by the force.

Bangul leaped in the air, flying toward the western tower bridge of the suspension bridge. She flew across the Magena River in a flash, and a thick chain dangled from her mouth. The cable was attached to the chain.

The fat arrow with a rope... No, Bangul, biting the chain, glided away into the sky. As she was sent forward, the long cable that followed her drew a straight, clean line in the air over the Magena River that stretched 260 yards in width. On the other side, a natural cushion was waiting to receive Bangul.

“Ppodong? Ppo-do-dong!”

The 32-foot Ppodong stood on his feet, bringing out his chubby belly with his outstretched arms. He sucked in a breath, and seconds later, Bangul flew and collided into him.

Bangul’s round head dug deep into Ppodong’s belly like an arrow. But even though the inertia made the blow extremely powerful, Ppodong was okay because several layers of his belly protected him from harm. The thick fur worked as the first line of defense, absorbing the force of the collision. Next, his thick leather lessened the impact, and at last, his flabby belly distributed the rest of the landing force. Ppodong reached out and wrapped his arms around Bangul, preventing her from being bounced off the impact. He rolled down on the ground, resolving to never let her go. The two summon creatures locked their gaze.

“Ppodong?”

“Bangul!”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“Bba-bangul!”

The two confirmed each of them were okay. Both flashed a happy grin, and Javier quickly moved his feet behind them.

“Now!” Lloyd shouted from the other end.

Javier stretched his hand and grabbed the chain, which Bangul carried from the other side. He held on to make sure that the chain and cable wouldn’t fall. It required him to use his manaheart and three mana circles.

“Arggh!”

Ppodong and Bangul sprinted in his direction, assisting Javier by grabbing the cable together. They endured and tugged. They tugged and grabbed. At last, the cable affixed to the end of the tether came into his reach. Then, he turned right away, carrying the cable over his shoulder. He started to walk forward toward his destination, where there was a socket that connected the cable to the bridge peak.

“Put it in!”

At last, the end of the cable was shoved into the socket right when Lloyd shouted out. The cable and socket fit perfectly as if the two were measured with a ruler. Right when Javier saw its entrance, he turned the socket, locked it, and fastened it safely. However, Javier wasn’t satisfied with the job. He quickly turned to the west side of the tower, where Lloyd was standing. That was when he knew he could rest assured.

“Success...!” Lloyd was waving his two arms toward him, and he could even hear the labored pants between the shouting. It looked like the other end was able to connect as well.

“Whew.”

Javier finally let out a sigh of relief after knowing that the most dangerous part of the job was now done, and Lloyd was safe. The latter alone was

good enough.

* * *

Even after that, a string of complicated tasks awaited them. The second act of construction resumed under the scorching sun that grew hotter as the day progressed. The main cables were connected from the rear areas of the towers, and they were installed at each anchorage of the tower. After that, Lloyd installed the fan trusses made from chains. To analogize, the main cables hung in the bridge towers looked like a clothesline, while the fan trusses took the shape of harp strings. There were dozens of them vertically stretched downward.

Ppodong played a stupendous role in this part of the job. To cut the long story short, Ppodong turned out to be a guru in riding ropes. He hopped and dangled on the cables even when his body stood more than thirty-two feet tall. The cable twanged and fluctuated as he moved, but he managed to run like he was on flat ground. Furthermore, hanging down there was a breeze for him as well. Sometimes, he went down the slide with his chubby belly.

“Ppo-do-dong!”

Every day, Ppodong repeated the process of crisscrossing over the cables, hanging countless fan trusses and fixing them. Once the installation of the fan trusses was done, one last major job remained, placing the bridge plates on the top and connecting everything. To this end, Lloyd first floated the plate on the river.

“I am very relieved,” said Lloyd.

“Relieved? About what?”

Wels Corgidus looked up at Lloyd. There was a smile of satisfaction on Lloyd’s face.

“It’s about the bridge plate I had ordered. The truss frames have been constructed to be much sturdier than I had expected.”

“Are you kidding me right now? Have you forgotten who constructed it?”

“Who else but the master in craft, Sir Corgidus.”

“Such excessive flattery. Anyway, you impertinent brat, what do you plan to do from now on?” Corgidus said as he exhaled.

“What do you mean what I’m going to do?”

“That.”

Corgidus pointed at the area near the river with his chin. There was a huge raft on the water, which was occupied by a portion of the bridge plate. Corgidus asked once more.

“Didn’t you say you planned on connecting the object on top of the fan truss?”

“Yes, I did.”

“It’s a good idea,” Corgidus continued, “to have it afloat on the water. But how are you going to transfer it up there?”

“Oh, about that.”

Lloyd chuckled when he received the question.

“I have my ways. The technique is called ‘Jack-up Down,’ and I’m trying to play around with it and apply it to my current situation.”

“Jack-up down?”

“Yes.”

“What is it?” inquired Corgidus.

“Uhm, to put it simply... You know what? Why don’t you just watch how it’s done?” suggested Lloyd.

“What?”

Instead of explaining, Lloyd simply grinned. He tried to come up with an explanation that would be understandable to people here, but he couldn’t. The same method had been used in building the Gwangan Bridge in Busan, South Korea. He could tell the dwarf that, but it wouldn’t mean anything. So, he simply shrugged. Such a vague answer worked to plunge Corgidus into deeper confusion.

Jack-up down or whatever. How is he going to lift that thing up?

Corgidus couldn’t wrap his head around it as he was fully aware of the size of the truss frame bridge plate he had produced.

I’d mobilized all the masters working for me, and it almost took us four months to create six plates. That’s how heavy they are. One block of the plate weighs well over one hundred tons.

So, it was a puzzle how Lloyd would lift the plates up to the fan truss. And the crease around his eyes was deepening in curiosity when...

“Hamang...!”

There was a loud, unexpected shout in the middle of the river. Right after that...*!*

“Eh? Something’s sucking the water!”

Suddenly, the river tumbled just like one of the crowds shouted. It swirled into a storm, and it suddenly sucked into a single point as though a hole was burrowed under the river bottom. At last, people and Corgidus could see what was happening. A hippopotamus was rapidly growing as it drank the water right under the raft!

“Hamang! Hamamang!”

Hamang shouted like thunder as he gulped down the river water. One sip. Two sips. His body swelled like a balloon each time he drank. There

seemed to be no limit to his expansion. He continued to grow thirty feet, sixty feet, and even 150 feet tall.

The raft moved on top of Hamang's back.

"Hamamang! Hamang!"

Hamang's body enlarged in size without stopping, and as a result, the raft on his back continued to elevate. 165 feet... 195 feet... 230 feet... Just at that point, Lloyd sent a signal.

"Hamang, stop!"

"Hamang...?"

"Could you pause drinking water for a second?"

"Hamamang? Hamang?"

"I'll let you drink more later!"

"Hamang!"

Just like that, Hamang's body stopped growing at 230 feet, and his height perfectly aligned the bridge plate on his back to the edge of the fan truss, which was 157 feet tall.

"All right! Let's go!" Lloyd shouted.

Lloyd led the waiting workers and headed to the bridge plate. Everyone connected a dozen strands of fan truss into the sockets. They connected one block after another, and it was repeated several times.

"Hamang!"

Hamang, who had gotten small while the workers connected the fan truss and plate, became large again and pushed the next block accordingly. Lloyd, Javier, and workers stood by at the top of the towers, and they assembled the plates and fan trusses. And they then connected the plates

with one another with the link-type joint connect device Lloyd had ordered previously. Instead of the welders, the magicians came and used fire magic to weld the plates. This process went on for several days. At last, the last block was connected.

The moment the last plate was inserted into the socket, a new message popped in front of Lloyd.

[You have finished constructing the suspension bridge in the royal capital Magenta.]

[You have successfully constructed the first large suspension bridge in the history of the Laurasian continent.]

[This new type of bridge will be deeply loved by people in the capital. Moreover, it will be named after the builder and his handsome knight, the “Llojavi Bridge.”]

[The “Llojavi Bridge” will settle as a new landmark in the royal capital Magenta.]

[Your name will be vividly marked in the civil engineering history of the kingdom and the continent for constructing the “Llojavi Bridge.”]

[For that significant achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 850 RP.]

[Current RP: 3,019]

It’s done.

The welcoming message notified him of his achievement. He could never get enough of it, and it never failed to fill him with joy. Lloyd flashed a big smile as he looked at it. The tediously long suspension bridge construction ended up a success. It felt real. Lloyd thought to himself that this RP reward was just the beginning. Something better would come, and he’d soon be

rewarded to the point that his stomach would burst in joy amid the overflowing number of rewards.

* * *

“I, Alicia Termina Magentano, declare henceforth.”

Queen Magentano’s voice echoed throughout the space with such dignity. She didn’t need to use magic to amplify her voice. She was a sword master, so imbuing mana into her voice to boom across the land was a breeze for her. Her voice reverberated majestically, and each time her mouth uttered, twenty magic-controlled golems moved in unison. Ten golems approached from the east and west side of the “Llojavi Bridge.” Then they marched toward the center of the bridge.

Each time their massive feet moved forward; the plate of the bridge trembled. But it didn’t collapse. Instead, it held up more flexibly, and at last, twenty golems gathered to the center of the bridge. Even till then, the bridge stood tall, majestic, and robust.

Twenty golems stopped at once, lining up behind the queen, who stood on the podium at the bridge center. The corners of the queen’s lips rose to form a satisfied smile.

“I hereby grant Lloyd Frontera, who has built this beautiful and sturdy bridge, the title of master craftsman.”

The sky was filled with hundreds of immaculate pigeons, and citizens gathered along the riverside to cheer for Lloyd. The previous bridge had posed a serious concern for them. They crossed holding their breath, fearing that the bridge might collapse due to the flood come spring. Their fear exacerbated when the bridge cracked in the spring. But they had to cross nonetheless to get to the other side of the river. They were like cats on hot bricks when they did, fearing that it might collapse without a warning. But to make ends meet, they were forced to cross it. That, however, was no longer necessary. For there was the beautiful and newly constructed suspension bridge, the Llojavi Bridge. It looked safe even in their untrained eyes.

Aside from the amazing shape that resembled a clothesline, it was amazing in that it didn’t have any piers submerged under water. This meant that no violent floods could impact the bridge. Its sturdiness was being put to the test right now. Even when twenty golems marched and gathered at the center, the bridge didn’t even budge.

“Lloyd! Lloyd!”

People’s cheers were mixed with Lloyd’s name. The shouting of his name grew louder until it became a unified outcry springing out of the crowd. It manifested the best form of respect and gratitude they could ever express in commemoration of the person who built a safe bridge for them. Lloyd’s shoulder shivered as he processed their fervent calling.

Woah...

Lloyd wondered if this was what it felt like to be a global K-pop star. He couldn’t believe this unrealistic and heart-thumping situation where the entire city called out his name. It was then followed by several praises from Her Highness. All sorts of rewards were announced one after another like a string of sausages. A hefty sum of compensation was paid, which was enough to cover the debt of the barony. On top of that, Lloyd was given a lifelong pension as an incentive.

It’s over. It’s finally over.

There was no greater reward in the world than money. Lloyd remained clutching his fists throughout the completion ceremony even as they were getting sweaty. Lloyd felt content and eclectic. It had been a year and a half since he came to this world under a new identity. And his earnest yearning to clear his debt was finally realized in real life.

Once I go back to the barony... I can just laze around for the rest of my life.

The debt problem was completely solved. He’d be on lifelong pension from the kingdom. No dramatic rebellion or anything since he was just a provincial noble. He’d be living the life of laziness for the rest of his life. Happiness overwhelmed Lloyd. So, he just needed to solve one issue, and it

had something to do with the resolution he had secretly formed several months ago when he brought Julian out of the academy. If he solved that, he could happily go back to the barony. Thinking such, he sought the exact time and tried to read the queen's mood. The queen was coming down the podium after the construction completion ceremony when he saw the chance. He quickly got on his knee and spoke in a somewhat resentful voice.

"Your Majesty, I give thanks and praise for your boundless generosity. However, if I may be so bold, I, Lloyd Frontera, alert you about a highly important matter."

"What is it?"

Queen Magentano was walking down the podium until Lloyd spoke. She paused and turned to his way.

"You have something to alert me? What is it?"

I've got her attention. It worked.

Lloyd smiled as he hung his head down. He had just received the title of master, as well as the queen's favor and trust. Now was the right time.

"The Magenta Royal Academy that is under your guidance continues to be the center of rotten corruption, inequality, and sordidness. Therefore, I humbly ask if that is within your knowledge."

"What is that... Corruption, which I am not aware of, is taking place at the academy?"

"It is unfortunately true, Your Majesty." Lloyd's voice dripped with resentment. But his lips twitched into a smile, but no one saw it. At last, the reaction he'd wanted came back.

"Do expound on the matter."

So, it began. The time to tell on the jerks who harassed the weak hiding behind their family status and the academy workers who turned a blind eye

to the whole situation. The time had come for Lloyd to put their heads on a platter. Thus, this began Lloyd's detailed tattling that was filled with nothing but the truth.

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Chapter 93: Tattling and Trickery (1)

A long, long time ago, there lived a private who was slow in movement. He got kicked in the shin all the time by his seniors. So one day, the private made a wish.

Dear stars above, please help me bond well with my seniors. And boom! The stars descended into the unit!

And the wrath of the two-star general carried the nasty-tempered senior to military prison. Oh, what a happy ending. A happy ending.

A corner of Lloyd's lips lifted upward. His days in the military came to his mind. He had a comrade who came into the military around the same time as Lloyd. The comrade was kind, but the military wasn't exactly the place where he thrived the most. He moved slowly, and was a bit socially slow as well. Making things worse, he was unlucky. Some of his seniors were foul-tempered, so they summoned him just to kick him in the shin. There were even worse things that happened to him. Fast forward a few months, almost breaking into tears, he confessed to Lloyd that he planned on running away from the base. Lloyd advised that he shouldn't be the one to leave. Instead, he ought to report the wrongdoings of his seniors. Two weeks later, the entire unit was turned upside down. The division commander visited to inspect the unit, and all of them were swept into military prison. It was the power of taking the courage to report. That was how he became happy. Happy ending.

Whew... The exact same thing happened today. Lloyd threw off his superfluous dress coat and tossed his necktie on the chair after loosening it. His tired body flung itself toward the sofa, and the pleasant fluffiness brought an onrush of sleepiness and the memories of events that had taken place during the day.

It's a relief. That everything went according to plan. There was a ceremony marking the completion of the suspension bridge, and the queen bestowed the title of master craftsman to Lloyd as well as the promised rewards and prestigious benefits. And in return, he told the queen about what was

happening down at the academy. He couldn’t forget the expression on Queen Magentano’s face was deathly.

“Corruption...? Inequality? And, on top of that, sordidness?”

The queen’s icy voice filled the air. Having a just and fair character, Queen Magentano especially despised the act of using wrongful force to harass the weak. It was something mentioned several times in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* That is, it was true until she lost an arm after an assassination attack. And so, Lloyd figured that tattling on the queen would work. Plus, she gave him full trust at this point in time. So now that he had the chance, he needed to make hay while the sun shone. Missing it would be a foolish thing to do. Convicted of such, Lloyd nodded at the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

This was the most important part. He needed to choose his words carefully. They had to be strategically ordered.

“Please forgive me for saying this, but the reality of the academy I have witnessed is extremely far from the mission of its existence.”

“Far from it?” said the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Do expound more,” she added.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

His scheme worked. Now, he spoke in a more forceful tone.

“The students, who are supposed to give everything to their studies, are only interested in forming cliques. Instead of competing with their knowledge and wisdom, they parade their family ranks and status. The sons of the marquess and count join as one to persecute the son of the viscount, and he is forced to trample the child of the baron. Furthermore, everyone is silent about it. When every minute should be spent on academics, they

indulge in the sweetness of power, and instead of forming great ambitions for a better world, students despair over the wall that is their family rank."

Lloyd was unreserved about letting out the harsh thoughts that he had held in until now.

"What is more, the attitude of the academy is no better than the students it should be guiding. The housemaster, who should be pointing out the wrong, accepts money behind everyone's back. Professors, who ought to be alarmed and fearful over the corruption of the world, are scared that they might make a bad impression on the nobles. And the dean, who has the duty to put an end to this wretched reality, is busy silencing the pitiful outcries for help from the students from less influential families."

What Lloyd said was true. Ever since Lloyd got Julian out of the academy, he used whatever time he had left in building the bridge to meet up with the cleaners and cafeteria workers in the academy. He even once visited a weak noble alumni. Countless testimonies and reports were revealed through them. Dirty corruption by the housemaster and dean and their practice of receiving bribery in exchange for turning a blind eye to all those were made plain. The sons of the powerful nobles acted more boldly, as though the world was theirs. A culture of corruption spread throughout the academy like rotten roots. Lloyd collected such witnesses, accounts, and pieces of evidence as much as possible. He fished the evidence out of his pocket, which was a rolled-up piece of paper.

"I have investigated when and where the workers in the academy took bribes for personal gains. In each item, I have attached the incident and witness right beside it."

"Spread it open," demanded the queen.

Lloyd opened it up according to the order and carefully handed it to her. Afterward, everything went smoothly. The pieces of evidence and witnesses were so perfectly organized in the paper that the queen's gaze changed the moment she checked. She looked like the division commander of Lloyd's comrade when he reported harassment in the military.

“This means that from now on, the queen’s going to summon everyone involved and beat the daylights out of them.”

Lloyd spoke as he was jostled out of his reverie. He turned to look at the door, and Julian was standing there. He had become darker than when Lloyd first saw him a few months ago, and his petite physique had grown a bit firmer. But his unique round and youthful impression was still the same. The boy mumbled as he looked to Lloyd’s side.

“Tell me if you got something to say,” Lloyd said as he tapped the side of the sofa with his hands.

Julian awkwardly approached, and instead of sitting in his designated seat, he remained standing, crinkling his nose.

“Uhm, so what’s going to happen from now on?” Julian muttered.

“What do you mean?”

“Them.”

“Do you mean the folks in the academy?” asked Lloyd.

“Yeah.”

“Are you worried?”

“It’s not that. I’m just curious.”

Surely, he would be curious, Lloyd thought to himself. After all, they harassed and bullied Julian for a long time. And there was a large group that remained silent about the whole thing. But now, they were seconds away before the iron mace of the queen hit them. Lloyd laughed.

“I don’t know.”

“Huh?” asked Julian, raising his brow.

“Who cares what happens to them. They can die, and I won’t care.”

“They might even die...?”

“Well, I don’t think the queen is going to punish them that severely. But...”

“But?”

“It’s going to sting considerably. Some might end up in jail for bribery, and a thrashing might await one young master. Some may even be confined to the manor and won’t be able to set foot outside for several years,” drawled Lloyd.

“...”

“And anybody who has an iota of involvement in your harassment will seriously have their future as a noble jeopardized. Why? Because they’ve been singled out by the most powerful person in the kingdom.”

“Wait, did you plan the whole thing from the beginning?”

“Somewhat.”

That was true. The moment he sought the opportunity to teach Diego a lesson and brought Julian out of the academy, he devised the plan to annoy, provoke, and destroy them.

“It’s really nothing complicated. I had just gotten the construction deal from the queen. Since the construction held much meaning to the royal circle, I thought that the success of the construction would let me earn some brownie points from her. And earning her trust like that would help me tattle on them,” explained Lloyd.

“...”

Lloyd shrugged as if it was nothing. Julia found himself gulping. There was something awesome about Lloyd. He was never like this. The man was a spontaneous drunkard who only caused trouble, but not anymore. Ever since Julian was forced into a LOA and dragged out of the academy, he received the feeling that Lloyd Frontera wasn’t an alcoholic hooligan

anymore. He didn’t drink. He became industrious. Most importantly, he was even gentle with him!

He never got angry at me for several months. A gentle and kind Lloyd Frontera. That was something unimaginable. Julian wondered at times if Lloyd was the same person he always knew.

Him being gentle... It was awkward at first, but it wasn’t so bad after a while. It was the same case with shoveling. This was the first time in his life he did an activity like that. So, it went without saying that the work exhausted him. For the first few days, muscle pain throbbed all over his body. Blisters appeared on his palm, and his skin became scraped. But such soreness and muscle pain hardly meant anything. It wasn’t anything compared to his agonizing days in the academy when he faced harassment on a daily basis.

Actually, I felt good. Julian sweated and shoveled all day. Something in him changed each time he used the tool. He moved the piles of sand, and Bangul chomped it up to produce wires. Ppodong interlaced the wires to turn them into cables, which were used to support the suspension bridge in the capital. Julian found satisfaction in the work. The entire process of construction was facilitated by his shoveling. So, in a way, his shoveling was what allowed the suspension bridge to be realized. An overwhelming sensation swept over him as he thought so. He felt confident. And just as his stamina increased after months of hard shoveling, Julian began to have more belief in himself.

It could be that Lloyd entrusted me with the job to make me feel this way. Julian’s gaze moved to Lloyd. He was scoffing in his loosened clothes. Lloyd was an older brother Julian had always hated and was ashamed of. But for the first time ever, Julian saw him differently. It could be, perhaps, that was what made Julian say something he never ever thought he’d tell Lloyd.

“Thank you.”

“What?”

“I said thank you,” Julian said louder this time.

“You must have eaten something weird.”

Lloyd spoke as he poked and scratched his ear. And then it occurred to Julian that he had made a mistake. Grimace formed on his face.

“Yeah. I think I did. I feel like vomiting,” said Julian.

“That’s the same thing for me. I feel like I’m going to puke from my ears.”

“Yeah? Well, I’ve got goosebumps right now.”

“Just goosebumps? Even the taste buds on my tongue stood up,” Lloyd said as he stuck his tongue out. Julian scoffed at him.

“By the way, Lloyd.”

“What is it?”

“When are you going back home?”

“Not sure. Maybe tomorrow?”

“Tomorrow? That soon?”

“Yeah.”

Lloyd nodded his head. There was no need to stay around here any longer.

“The construction is finished, and I received everything I need from the queen. So, it’s time to go back to the fiefdom. A mountain of work await me since I’ve started a lot of projects there, too.”

It was true. The coal mine, Maritz land, and waterway. He had several things to check over.

“Plus, I’ve earned enough to pay the debt. If I goof and stick around here, I might be arriving after the interest date. I’d have to pay the interest again.

So, I have to pay every penny of my debt before the interest date comes up."

"Oh, that is so true. But you see..." Julian scratched his cheek. "I didn't know about it, actually."

"Didn't know what?" asked Lloyd.

"The debt you mentioned."

"Oh. The debt?"

"Yeah, I really didn't know since all I did was study here. My parents sent me letters every month, but they never ever once mentioned it. So, I was entirely in the dark that they had it so rough back there."

Julian hung his head down as shame started to creep up inside him. He had thought that he had it the toughest among his family. He was the one living a hard life away from home, and he had it worse because he withstood the harassment even when studying alone was difficult to keep up with. So, he considered himself proud for enduring the situation and not telling his parents. But when he learned about their financial situation, he gained a new perspective. Javier had explained everything to him about how his father got conned, how much debt his family owed, and how Lloyd acted differently amid such a situation.

"At first, I was a bit skeptical," confessed Julian.

"How can I when he told me that you changed. Sir Asrahan told me that you are really awesome. Sometimes, you can be petty but you're trying very hard. He said that the family would have collapsed into ruins if it weren't for you."

Javier's words fell like bombshells. Julian clenched and unclenched his fists several times and sighed at length as he imagined the pain and suffering his family had to go through. When that fact was made clear to Julian, he severely rebuked himself.

It turned out that I had it the easiest. But Julian didn’t know that. He simply grumbled that Lloyd would be the same as before. He acted like a child.

“So I’m sorry.”

“You’re sorry?”

“Yeah.”

Julian nodded, even though he couldn’t meet Lloyd in the eyes. He was too embarrassed. Still, Julian had mustered up the courage to say it. The only chance to say so was today since Lloyd would be returning to the fiefdom the next day. He had to say what he wanted to say now. And so, he carefully uttered the very words he had wanted to say for a few months but was too shy to say out loud.

“I’m not going to hate you anymore.”

Just then...

Ding Dong.

[Julian Frontera is being sincere with you.]

[Julian Frontera’s resentment is going away.]

[Julian Frontera has accepted you as his older brother.]

[Your likeability with Julian Frontera has increased by 65 points.]

[Current RP with Julian Frontera: +6]

[You have earned 910 RP by slightly improving your relationship with the main character.]

[Current RP: 3,929]

[The intimacy level with Julian Frontera has increased three levels from <Hatred> and <Awkward> and <Apathy> to <Average Regard>.]

[You have earned 100 RP as a bonus for the improvement.]

[Current RP: 4,029]

Unexpected, sweet, and satisfying emotions knocked on the door to Lloyd's heart.

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Chapter 94: Tattling and Trickery (2)

“Oh, you little boy...”

Lloyd grinned without realizing it. He couldn’t help but feel happy and content as he stared at Julian standing in front of him. But at the same time, a deep sense of embarrassment swelled in him when he thought back to what Julian had just said.

“So you’re not going to hate me anymore?” asked Lloyd.

“Um, no...”

“That means that you used to hate me a lot.”

“Yes, I did,” admitted Julian.

“How are you going to treat me from now on?” Lloyd demanded.

“I... I... Um...”

“With a lot of affection?”

“Um, no. Not like that.”

“Then, how? By being friendly?” demanded Lloyd once again.

“...”

“With a lot of warmth and love and softness?”

“…Ugh, seriously?” Julian spoke as he grimaced.

A teasing smile spread across Lloyd’s face. “Now you know what you just did, eh?”

“Whew, yeah.”

“Really toe-curling, isn’t it?” asked Lloyd again.

“Yeah.”

“I even got goosebumps up to the tip of my toes.”

“...”

“Don’t you ever say something that cheesy again,” said Lloyd.

“...”

“Whew, I thought I was going to get a seizure, really,” Lloyd emphasized as he tapped and stroked his belly.

Even though his tone was teasing, Lloyd didn’t feel offended. In all honesty, Lloyd was instead endlessly elated and delighted. It had little to do with earning a lot of RP. No. Although he was satisfied with the reward of RP in front of him, the contentment in his heart satisfied him much more. At that moment, he suddenly recalled his childhood.

I wish I’d had a younger brother back then.

Anybody with a brother would freak out and immediately advise Lloyd to get rid of the thought, but Lloyd was serious about it because he had grown up as an only child. Throwing a tantrum at his parents became his strategy to make them get him one. He demanded that he wanted to play with someone younger, like the neighborhood kids. One day, he even drew doodles on the wall with some crayons. They were of the popular robot, Gundam. Any boy would have recognized it at the time. About five inches shorter than his height, the robot posed in a V-shaped with his outstretched arms. Lloyd even colored the drawing. That night, his parents came home to a surprising doodle of a robot on the wall, and Lloyd confidently told them that the robot was his younger brother from now on. His parents merely smiled in bitterness and embarrassment without scolding him. He didn’t know at the time, but it was revealed many years later that he was an IVF baby.

Whew... Stop thinking about it.

Sometimes, no, on rare occasions, memories of his past intruded his thoughts, plunging him into unexpected and unnecessary nostalgia. He let out a soft sigh and pressed the pieces of ambushing memories back into his mind. Then, he stared at Julian and spoke.

“Anyway, I’m going back to the barony tomorrow. Oh, that is after I attend an event later tonight,” said Lloyd.

“What do you have later?” asked Julian.

“Oh, Her Highness told me earlier that she wants me to attend a party this evening. She said it’s going to be awesome.”

“A party?”

“Yeah, a banquet hosted by the royal family, celebrating the construction of the bridge. I can already see what’s going to happen there. The orchestra playing music. The nobles wander around to form connections. Then, a rude young noble eventually gets challenged to a duel. It’s the same old same old,” drawled Lloyd in boredom.

“Brother, you have become very imaginative.”

“I’ll take you to mean that I’ve become smart,” said Lloyd. “Anyway, you should come along.”

“Eh? Me too?” Julian’s eyes grew wide.

“Of course,” Lloyd said as he chuckled. “You are the younger brother of the master hand. That alone gives you the right to come. And besides...”

Lloyd’s voice turned meaningful. “You will meet a lot of powerful nobles at this banquet.”

“Um, so that means...”

“There will be families whom I tattled on.”

“Doesn’t that make it a little awkward?” Julian said with hesitation in his voice.

“No, you must attend with your chin held high. You’ve done nothing wrong. You’re the victim. Yet, you’re trying to hide? Nonsense.”

It was true. Julian had to be confident, especially in situations like these. He had to be thick-skinned and callous as if he had a titanium plate on his face.

“So, let’s take this chance to give you some ego. Okay? It’ll make your life easier moving forward.”

“All right. Okay.”

Julian nodded in understanding. Lloyd felt content again, seeing how smart the boy is. He then resolved it in his heart as well.

Tonight’s not going to be a simple celebration. It’ll be something more.

The queen wasn’t clumsy. She would want to keep Lloyd by her side. Whether it be a magnificent position or a jaw-dropping prize, she would offer him such sweet rewards in exchange for making him stay in the capital. That was why she called him up here and tested his abilities in the first place.

I, too, am not going to go so easy on her.

Lloyd’s dream remained the same. He wanted to become a rich man. He didn’t want to suffer anymore. He didn’t want to work too hard, either. He simply wanted to pay his debts and become a couch potato in the barony. So, the time had come for Lloyd to play one more trick so he could happily go back home to his barony.

The soft and slow melody traveled throughout the marble floor, and the glimmers of the chandeliers flowed down like starlight. The banquet hall was unbelievably luxurious and majestic. Amidst everything, Lloyd was dressed in a tuxedo. As he noticed Her Highness approaching, he paid his respect and started talking, almost in a scripted manner.

“All hail Her Majesty. Please forgive me for saying this, but no,” said Lloyd.

“No...? What do you mean?” Queen Magentano quirked her brow sharply to one end. Once again, just like any other time, she noticed how brazen and unpredictable he was.

“I have not asked anything yet,” said the queen. “But what is it that you dislike so much that you reject it before I ask?”

“Were you not going to say that you will be bestowing me with land and a title befitting my skills?” asked Lloyd.

“I was?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Why?”

“So that I shall accept a position in this palace.”

“Hmm... Tell me, can you read minds?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“I can read the room,” explained Lloyd briefly.

“Ha.”

Clink.

The queen laughed shortly and put down the crystal glass in her hand. She then grabbed a new one from the serving tray and sipped it as she glanced down at Lloyd through the slightly slanted glass.

“I have no choice but to admit it. Yes, your presupposition is right. I planned on rewarding you with a fitting land, title, and massive amounts of

gold. Moreover, I meant to give you a position in the palace that suits you."

"Did you host the banquet to announce to everyone about this?" asked Lloyd.

"Indeed."

She drank from the second glass. The first glass was a dry, sparkling one with high acidity. The next one was a flavorful red wine. It was the typical order of drinking the queen enjoyed. Keeping the routine, she said, "Therefore, I am curious. Why do you reject it when I am ready to bestow you with the title, land, money, and position?"

"It's nothing extraordinary, Your Majesty. But..."

"But?"

"I like living in the quietude of the province."

"Is that all... there is?" asked the queen.

"Yes, Your Majesty."

Lloyd hung his head down a little lower. The queen was drinking her third glass now. And as he studied her reaction, he thought to himself...

Good. Everything's going according to plan.

Just then, he recalled what had happened earlier in the day. Right until he set foot in this banquet tonight, Lloyd mulled over how he should reject the queen's inevitable offer to work for the palace. Even when he got dressed, touched up his hair, and hopped into the carriage, Lloyd thought and thought again about it. He finally concluded that the standard tactics were the best method.

I might be cornered into accepting it by giving clumsy excuses.

In actuality, Lloyd could come up with a whole trove of excuses. First off, he could say that he or his family was sick. Or that he was crushed under

work and that he wasn’t ready. Everything around him could be used as an excuse. Just like how everyone made up an excuse to skip class, leave school early, or take a day off work, Lloyd could lie. But he remembered someone saying that the only person who succeeded in life by giving out excuses was an artist who sang the song “Excuse.” Lloyd believed in that, and that this principle applied just the same to him.

The moment I make up an excuse, I’ll be setting myself up to be caught in a trap.

If health was an issue, he could get better anytime. It went the same for family situations or business. The moment the source of his excuse evaporated in thin air, he would have no escape. What was more, the person Lloyd was dealing with was the queen. And so, coming up with dimwit excuses to reject a position in the royal palace may backfire and Lloyd could have no choice but to accept it later on.

I’ll end up the same as Minister Hwang Hee.

At the end of the Goryeo period in ancient South Korea, there lived Hwang Hee, who took the same test as the Taejong of Joseon, Yi Bangwon. In the future, Hwang was appointed by King Sejong, the son of Yi, and toiled away his entire life for the country without any second of rest. He pleaded in vain that he needed to take some rest. He used his health and family as excuses, but it was as if he was talking to a wall. His whole life was spent putting his nose to the grindstone for the government, and just like that, the man died doing nothing but work his entire life.

Ugh... I have the chills.

Lloyd shuddered at the thought, his shoulders trembling. No thanks to lifelong slavery. He concluded that it would be better for him to opt for the standard tactics than to come up with perfunctory excuses. That promised a higher chance of his victory in this situation. When he put this into action, he was able to secure the result he desired.

“I see. You hate it so much that you dare to be this forthcoming with me, the queen.”

“Please forgive my rudeness, Your Majesty.”

“Not at all. Nothing good will come out of pinning you down here when you have no desire to remain in this place. How can you fulfill your duties when your heart's not in it?”

The queen paused after saying that, smiling.

“I am not a tyrant. You are a loyal subject who has done great deeds for this capital and for Cremo. I shall respect your decision. Therefore, go back to your home and spend the rest of your life in peace.”

“Words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Highness.”

“Really?”

“...”

“You must be relieved on the inside. I know what you are going through. That is why I give you my word. If you change your mind, do come to the capital,” assured the queen”

Lloyd paused at her words. Then he said, “Do you mean... that Your Majesty’s offer has no expiration?”

“Indeed,” confirmed the queen.

Clack.

Taking a sip from a fourth glass, the queen said, “I swear by my name. Your land, title, and position will always be waiting for you in the capital.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“I hope you do. Now, I will take my leave.”

Lloyd heard the queen turn around and walk away. The clacking of her heels started to grow distant. That was when he slightly lifted his head.

“Woah.”

The air that was stifled in his lungs rushed out, and he found himself clenching his fist.

It worked!

Lloyd exclaimed inwardly because his choice of tactic worked.

I mean, even the queen can’t force someone to work for her when he doesn’t want to.

Just then, Lloyd recalled *The Records of the Three Kingdoms*, and the famous three visits of Liu Bei to make Zhuge Liang join him. And so, Lloyd thought the same thing would happen here since this world was no different from the one he lived in. Thankfully, his prediction was spot on”

And since I was promised she’d save some land and a title for me, my future is secure. My later years are promised to be good. Perfect.

The thought of this brought a satisfying smile all over his face. Everything was set. His debt was cleared. The only thing that awaited him was a luxurious life of laziness. Lloyd felt as though he had gotten a newly constructed house without a loan in the most expensive city district in the country, bought a high-end car in one payment, enough resources to pay for the kids’ school, university, and wedding, and to top it all off, his retirement plan was all covered.

Whew. How I wish I could hop back into the carriage and go to the barony at this moment. But since I can’t do that, I should just sit back and eat the exquisite food.”

Thinking such in his head, Lloyd moved around the buffet like a person who had starved for the past three days. He approached the servants holding up the food trays, and just then, something made him stop dead in his tracks.

“The banquet will continue until the moon sets.”

Huh?

Those seemingly innocuous words traveled into Lloyd's ears, and they sounded plain and harmless to others. But not to Lloyd. The moment he heard them, he felt numb, as though a bucketful of ice water splashed down on his body. He gulped.

Why am I hearing this now?

Just then, Lloyd recalled *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* After two and a half years, the royal capital goes through something tragic. An assassination attempt on the queen. There was a code shared by the group that took one of her arms after poisoning Queen Magentano. It was so simple that it didn't attract any suspicion.

The banquet will continue until the moon sets...

Since it was meant to happen much later, Lloyd could not be hearing that now. This should've come two and a half years later. But now that he heard the code, he turned to its speaker. His gaze locked on Sir Kyle, the commander of the royal guard, who was happily chatting with the Great Lord Chamberlain. Chills ran down his spine. At that moment, Lloyd was sure in his heart that he had discovered the culprit behind the veiled assassination of the queen, which wasn't even revealed in the novel.

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Chapter 95: Tainted Crown (1)

“Whew. I must have drank too much.”

Clack. Clack. The clicking noise of heels filled the hallway. Queen Magentano smiled meaningfully.

But I didn’t drink more than I usually do.

She felt nauseated, and her heart beat a little faster than usual.

I must have worked too much lately.

She looked back at her schedule as she walked across the hallway. Each day was another challenge yet to be finished.

The flood damage from the spring rain was greater than I expected, and the wasteland in the east is concerning as well.

Enemies surrounded the kingdom, and there were a lot of powerful figures that yearned for her downfall. Among their enemies, the sultan kingdom “Asfahan” over the eastern range of the wilderness was her nemesis. She had battled against them twice already.

Something is not right.

She had planted spies in Asfahan. Their reports came to her mind. They said that the kingdom had been increasing its weaponry in recent days. They were concentrating their forces against the western region that faced her kingdom. This couldn’t be simple military training.

Invasion maybe? No. A vast wasteland stands between us. If they were vying to attack us, they would have gathered the forces up north where both territories meet. So, what could it be?

The question left her wondering for several months. But no answer came to her mind, especially now when she was inebriated.

Tsk. I need to put it out of my mind for a while.

Her smile deepened. Thinking about it now solved nothing. It would only add unnecessary stress. So, she decided to focus on the present, sober up, and get back to the hall. She entered her exclusive resting room and leaned against the comfortable sofa. After drinking a cold glass of water, she caught her breath to regain some focus in her mind. It didn't work though. Her stomach still churned with nausea, and her palpitations didn't get any calmer. She breathed fainter and faster than usual.

Something's off.

She furrowed her brow. There was no one else that knew her body better than herself. She was a sword fighter that rose to the level of a sword master. Sobering up from slight intoxication was a breeze for her. Supposedly. She just had to control the mana in her system. But that wasn't working very well at the moment. Now, her vision grew dizzy and faint.

Something's gone wrong.

Thump! Thump! Her heart started to beat faster. She started to break out in a cold sweat. She got down from the sofa as an ominous feeling rushed through her. Removing her shoes, she let her body collapse to the floor. And she sat down, straightened her back, and started to breathe properly. Her heart was awakened. The powerful manaheart moved at her calling.

I should inspect every corner of my body first.

She pushed the fully loaded mana through the manaheart into every vein inside her. And the mana, which was like a node spread throughout her whole body, started to storm in her. At that moment, she reflexively clutched her chest.

Sink!

"…!"

The shock almost bent her back. The pain almost burst her heart.

“Argh!”

Everything before Queen Magentano was starting to drain in color and turn white. She fought to stay awake, not to lose consciousness. In a frantic manner, she put her hands on the floor and got to her feet, clenching her molars.

Poison? It couldn’t be.

She hoped not. But the pain that started from her heart spread all throughout her body in an instant. It was flowing along the mana within her vein, attacking every corner of her organs. There was only one explanation behind this.

Poison? How?

The queen gritted her teeth. The servants inspected her food and drink and tasted every one of them. They waited for four days to see whether they showed any symptoms or signs of illness. Only after that four-day process did the food make it to her table.

It was the same today.

The food and drink she had eaten at the banquet passed the same procedure as any other day. And no servants had died or passed out.

So what happened?

She wondered how this happened, but there was no way of knowing. She could only speculate. There was a mole behind the process of checking the food.

I should... call someone...

She needed help. The poison was spreading even now. The more she attempted to suppress it using the mana, the faster and wider the poison would spread. Queen Magentano yelled, squeezing every strength in her.

“Is someone... out there?!”

But no one answered. That was something else that was sketchy.

Dammit.

She did ask the servants to leave before she entered this room. But not without the instruction to wait outside the door. It was strange that no one answered.

“Argh... Argh!”

Staggering sideways, she hobbled toward the door as her hands propped against the wall. Her consciousness grew fainter every step of the way. She had to bite her lip hard to remain conscious. It was merely a few steps, but her mind blinked on and off like a light switch.

It’s too far.

The distance she would have easily traveled with a leap felt far now. The rest area was too wide. Though she moved with much strength, the distance ahead of her was greater than how much she traveled. She let out a chuckle at the ridiculousness of this situation. How did she get into such a mess? She wondered. She was about to plunge into despair when...

Clack. Like a miracle, the door opened. It was the man she was the closest with.

“Sir Kyle?”

The man she trusted the most. The royal commander that protected her at all times, her teacher in sword fighting, and her fellow sword master. Her face brightened when she saw him. Trying to not lose dignity, she spoke.

“Sir Kyle... Just in time... I am glad that you are here amid this difficult time. Here, my hand.”

She held out her hand toward the commander, smiling in the hopes that he would help her. Sir Kyle smiled at her the same.

“Yes, I am glad that I am with you, Your Highness, at this difficult time,” he stated.

But he didn’t take her outstretched hand. Instead, his hand moved to the hilt of his sword.

“Once a monarch of the kingdom. May you rest in peace.”

Fatal hostility flashed through his eyes.

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“It looks like the queen is in danger.”

“Excuse me...?”

Lloyd’s whisper came as a surprise. Javier cocked his head to the side.

“I do not know what you mean.”

At first, he thought Lloyd was making a nasty joke. But when he looked into Lloyd’s eyes, he knew he was serious.

“I’m telling you. Be quiet and lower your voice.”

“...”

“I’ll tell you the details later. Just follow me.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

Javier nodded, knowing that if his words were true, there was no time to goof around and stall. The details and explanation could come later. It was time to move, but not too closely. A few steps away from him. Lloyd instructed him through his eyes. Javier, who was quick to take hints, stepped away. And he asked Lloyd through his gaze.

Where are we going?

Over there.

Lloyd's eyes pointed to an area near the ball. That was where the resting room for the queen was located.

It's obvious. The queen is nowhere to be seen, and that's the only place where she could be.

The monarch was still human, so there would be times when she got drunk and tired during banquets. That was why there was a rest area for her, so she could sober up or get some air without losing her dignified air in front of people.

That's also the place where they attempt to assassinate her in the novel.

The story popped up in his mind just then. The incident happened two and a half years from now. It was the day it snowed for the first time that year. Queen Magentano almost died from poison when she stopped by the resting area during the ball. But she impressively used her mana ability, befitting the status of a sword master, and barely made it out alive. The assassination attempt fundamentally changed the destiny of the kingdom.

But it happens today? Why?

He couldn't wrap his head around why it was happening two and a half years earlier. He came up with various speculations, but nothing really stood out except for one.

Something changed.

The plot must have been altered for some reason. If that was the case, he might be the reason behind it, thought Lloyd to himself.

Let's check it out first.

Not too hastily. Just naturally as they blended in with the people at the banquet. Sometimes drinking from a cup with elegance. Passing by the servants with a smile. Doing such things, they removed themselves from the hall and entered the long hallway. Lloyd and Javier walked side by side, and

their walking became faster. Lloyd quickly formed a plan in his head, but he was a bit nervous about it.

Why did it have to be Sir Kyle, really, out of all the people?

Lloyd recalled what he had heard a while ago about how the banquet would last until the moon set. That harmless line was actually pretty famous amongst the readers of the novel. This was because the line was the code shared among the assassins that altered the history of the kingdom. So, Lloyd knew the line as well. The problem came from the fact that the person who said it was Sir Kyle.

If the assassin is really Sir Kyle, can we stop him?

Sir Vergado Kyle. The commander of the royal guards and an even greater sword master than the queen. It was shocking that he could be the assassin. But more than that, Lloyd was anxious about whether they would stand a chance against him. As such, Lloyd was of two minds about saving the queen.

I mean, we could be the ones that are done for.

He was hesitant, so he thought about it for a few minutes. Save the queen or turn a blind eye to her? Lloyd meticulously weighed the pros and cons between the two options. And at last, he arrived at a decision.

It's a bit risky, but it's more beneficial to save the queen.

Actually, there was no reason for Lloyd to mull over this. Queen Magentano had unreserved trust in him at the moment, to the point of granting excessive favors. And should she fall into the tragedy in the novel, losing an arm and becoming a tyrant...

It'd be a big loss for me.

The queen cherished and trusted Lloyd very much, willing to bestow land and a title at any time. Her fondness and favor for Lloyd were unrivaled, so Lloyd had the most powerful person in the whole kingdom as his supporter.

What would happen if she got poisoned, lost an arm, and became a massacring tyrant?

Goodness, I don't even want to think about it.

He could be degraded into her punching bag, not to mention the fact that he would be losing his greatest supporter. He might wound up in a tragedy where he could get framed for wrongful sins. His family status, title, and property would go down the flames. Worse, he could end up beheaded.

So, I've got no other option but to save her.

Even if it meant his opponent was Sir Kyle, Lloyd needed to trust Javier and get there fast.

Sprint! Lloyd and Javier were now running, but something was strange. They saw no one during their run through the long hallway. No servants or maids they usually saw. Turning the corners three times and moving up the stairs, they traveled a long way, but no one was in sight.

"Something is definitely sketchy."

Javier's voice turned low and icy.

Suppressing his nervousness, Lloyd asked, "Are you sure you're going to be okay?"

"Excuse me?" Javier arched one of his brows as he ran.

"Your sword. You don't have it."

"I will be fine."

Clang! Javier wielded his right hand at the same time he answered, and he snapped the candlestick hanging on the hallway wall. The snapped candlestick turned a few times in the air as it reflected the light. Javier grabbed the lower part.

Thwack!

“This will be enough.”

They were unarmed for the banquet, but now, that problem was solved. Next, when they took the last corner to the entrance, they met a horrifying scene. There was a pool of blood on the floor of the door to the rest area. Six servants lay in the bloody puddle, all of them not breathing. It only meant one thing.

Slam! They both kicked and rushed into the room, the door smashing in half. Two people were in there. Sir Kyle pressing his sword down, and the queen, struggling to block it. Javier reacted first as he saw the scene.

Slash! The candlestick in Javier’s hand slashed the air, creating a string of ferocious wind invisible to the eyes. Sir Kyle moved his sword.

Clang! Clang! Clang! The candlestick and sword collided several times, and the burning fire danced in the air. Javier’s veins in his right popped, and Sir Kyle frowned. The two beastly eyes met one another. Lloyd passed by the fight right away and made way for the queen.

“Lloyd Frontera...?”

“I am sorry, but I need you to keep your mouth shut now.”

“What...? Argh...”

Lloyd’s large hand cupped her mouth. And he gently forced her to lie on the ground without sparing a second of resistance. His actions would have normally been unacceptable, but right now, the queen was poisoned all throughout her body. Since Lloyd knew that he did away with all his menial mannerisms and etiquette. He merely focused on healing her.

“I’ll get the poison out first. Relax your body. Loosen up.”

Ziiing! Lloyd placed his palm on her stomach, and he rotated the three circles at their highest speed, absorbing the mana inside her body.

“…!”

Queen Magentano’s eyes flew open in horror.

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Chapter 96: Tainted Crown (2)

Zing! Javier's three circles rotated at varying speeds. At times, they amplified the spin of one another, and some other times, they slowed only to burst with speed again. As the circles criss-crossed together, Javier freely discharged mana and harnessed it into the candlestick that stabbed and slashed through everything in front of it.

Clang! The candlestick hit the sword, igniting fiery sparks in the air, and one of the sticks was slashed in half. The sword shot upward only to then aim for Javier's neck. Javier responded by tilting his head to the side by an inch.

Slash. The sword brushed an inch away from Javier's nose, and Sir Kyle's attack failed to warrant a single hair strand of damage. Javier's icy eyes traveled over to the enemy, and Sir Kyle's eyes widened in surprise.

What in the world was that?

Sir Kyle, the commander of the royal guards, gazed at Javier with evident astonishment in his eyes.

He avoided that?

Sir Kyle believed he had aimed his sword correctly. The timing, the sword trajectory, and the silver-haired stripling's staggering balance assured him so. Not a single enemy ever managed to avoid his sword under such conditions. But today was an exception. This youth avoided his perfect blow with nothing but a simple tilt of his head!

Has he been reading my sword's trajectory?

A shiver ran down his spine, but he instantly shook it off with a scoff. Who was he anyway? One of the two sword masters in the kingdom! There was no chance that he would get beaten by this young novice.

"You are nothing but a baby!"

Bam! Sir Kyle stomped the ground hard, and a cloud of shockwaves shifted the balance of his weight. He tugged his sword at lightning speed and wielded it with the force of his weight and mana.

Fwoosh! The sword laterally swayed to burst through the air, and Javier wasn't allowed another second to avoid the incoming blow after escaping the previous one.

"Argh...!"

This time, Javier grimaced from the shockwaves produced by the ripple of air. Their force hit him all over his body, so there was only one way he could respond.

Slash! Slash! Clang!

Javier brandished the candlestick at a speed faster than the wind, and as his motion created more ripples of air, it created a shockwave as well.

Kaboom! Javier's shockwave collided against Sir Kyle's, and they shoved and wrestled until they disappeared in thin air. Fright rushed through Sir Kyle's eyes.

"Where did this boy come from… Eh?"

Crackle! Sir Kyle wasn't spared a second to finish his sentence as he noticed that Javier was charging at him. Javier hurtled toward the sword master, penetrating the vanishing shockwave. He hooked, pointed, stabbed, and jabbed upward, cornering Sir Kyle at a breathtaking speed.

Corner him. Don't give him any time to breathe.

Javier objectively judged the situation and calculated his moves. The flow of victory formed so clearly inside him. His eyes sank coldly.

It is beyond me why the commander of the royal guard attempted to assassinate Her Highness. No matter, it is irrelevant to this duel. There's only one thing I should remember, and it's that I must corner and question him.

Javier laser-focused on the person standing in front of him. He tried to get a read of the man's fighting tactics and style.

Sir Kyle is a sword master. As soon as I spare him a second, he's going to create an aura sword. I'd be back against a wall if that were to happen. So come hell or high water, I must prevent him from creating an aura sword and drag this fight out as long as possible.

Javier stole his glance at the queen and Lloyd.

Poison.

He could vaguely paint a picture of what was happening. The queen had been poisoned, and Lloyd was trying to get it out of her system using the Asrahan Core Technique. That left Javier with only one job, and it was to buy time for Lloyd to resuscitate the queen"

"The sword! Over here!" shouted Javier"

Clang! At that instant, the candlestick broke into pieces, leaving Javier empty-handed. Sir Kyle didn't waste the opportunity. He rushed toward Javier.

Swish! Clack! Slash!

The incoming sword aimed at Javier's heart, arms, and legs. Javier stepped back and twisted his body, changing his step. Then, he stretched out his hand backward.

"Take this!"

Javier heard Lloyd shouting, and he noticed a sword flying in his direction. It was the queen's sword that Lloyd hurled toward him. Javier gripped the sword.

Clang! The two swords clashed. Javier's blue eyes. Sir Kyle's furrowed eyes. The two glared at each other ferociously between the two swords. Balance of powers. Search and identification. Confrontation. Silent but fierce. Their breaths were even. Each of them read the slight movement of

their eyes, which were mixed with a thirst for blood and lies. Sir Kyle spoke to Javier, his words much like his schemes.

“So, the rumors of what you did back at Cremo against the Gigatitan weren’t exaggerated,” said Sir Kyle.

“...”

“But it is strange. You don’t look to be at the level of a sword master. How are you dodging my sword?” he continued.

“...”

“Ha. Are you not going to answer me? Or are you just so busy that you can’t talk?”

“...”

Clang! Javier shoved Sir Kyle’s sword with force, bouncing it away and giving him a split second of time that he used to look back at Lloyd. He spoke to the young master with his gaze...

I’ll make you some time.

All right, but be careful.

The two gazed locked for a split second, only to tear away right after. Javier started to corner Sir Kyle.

Ziiing! Lloyd made two circles collide, and the blast created a massive force, which jetted out an explosion.

Thwack! The fierce mana blast shot toward Sir Kyle. His eyes widened.

“…!”

Slam! Sir Kyle clumsily brandished his sword and narrowly avoided the blow. He was sent almost seven yards away and smashed against the wall outside the rest area of the queen.

Thwack!

“Argh!”

The force from the blow made his shoulder, arm, and sword sting.

This is such a brutish attack...

Kaboom!

The second mana blast fired at him. Sir Kyle dared not block it this time again. He simply ducked down in a hurry and avoided the blow.

Crash! The blast hit the ground he was just standing on, but now it bore a hole that was about 20 inches deep.

“...”

Sir Kyle had never heard of or experienced this type of attack, and never in his wildest imagination did he think that a sword could enable it.

He’s a dangerous one.

Sir Kyle sharpened his senses in alarm. He no longer thought of him as a novice. Making things worse, the fighting location had grown more unfavorable for him.

Kaboom! Boom!

“Argh!”

The mana blast came in strings. Sir Kyle closely avoided each one.

It’s too narrow here!

They were in a long, narrow corridor, and the mana blast that stretched dozens of steps came flying at him, leaving him no chance to fight back. There was too much distance to do so. Standing on the ground already took a heavy toll on him, let alone allow him to counterattack. He wished he

could conjure an aura sword. It would've made slicing through these blows a piece of cake. But the silver-haired boy didn't give him the time he needed to focus and create the aura. Sir Kyle started to grow anxious.

I was on the fence about slaying the queen with my aura because it'd leave a trace. Never thought that it'd come back to bite me"

Grit! Sir Kyle recalled his mission to make sure that the queen was dead. So, he had to return to the rest area. But first, he had to deal with the silver-haired novice who appeared out of nowhere and confronted him with abilities that rivaled his own. No, he was instead winning against him using a powerful technique Sir Kyle had never seen before.

Is he trying to make me keep far away from the queen?

Sir Kyle furrowed his brows. Javier charged forward as he kept shooting his mana blast down the long, narrow corridor. Sir Kyle drew back against his will. Javier pushed ahead while Sir Kyle got pushed back. Javier fired the mana blast while Sir Kyle barely avoided it. Javier grew tired, while Sir Kyle became tenacious. After much shoving and pushing, Sir Kyle, who continued to jump back, was finally pushed out of the corridor.

Boom! Sir Kyle leaped back to avoid the mana blast once again, landing on the red carpet of the vast banquet hall. Glasses clanked, tables thudded, and people screamed. The chandelier dropped from the ceiling. Another scream. And Javier stood firmly on the ground at the entrance of the corridor, like a gatekeeper.

Swish. The queen's sword in Javier's hand glinted. Its shining glimmer held a clear message: No one could set foot in the corridor. No one.

"Ha! You insolent fool."

A ferocious smile spread across Sir Kyle's face, his skin wet and dripping with sweat. Now he understood. It became clear to him why Javier had cornered him this far.

He's trying to buy time.

There was no exit in the corridor. The young sword fighter just needed to protect one end of the hall. And should he get pushed deeper...

Did he decide that he'd be able to buy some time if he pushed me out of the corridor without dying?

The corners of his lips rolled upward as he finally shed light on Javier's plan. A counterplan came to his mind just then.

Well, I have my own plan too.

Sir Kyle quickly scanned every corner of the banquet hall that was now deathly quiet without the music and conversation. Groups of sharp-eyed men had their hands on their waists. They were all familiar faces. They were the royal knights he commanded over. They were waiting for his order.

They are oblivious to my betrayal and what happened back in the rest area. So, they'll listen to my words since I'm still their commander"

The smile on his face deepened.

"Hear my knights!" said Sir Kyle, his voice dripping with dignity. He then held up his sword high and pointed at Javier standing at the entrance.

"That man over there dared to plot treason in the capital. He has tried to assassinate Her Majesty with his accomplice, and now he has taken Her Highness hostage, attempting to take over the corridor. My dear knights! Raise your swords for the protection of Her Majesty!"

Right after his order was made...

Clang! Dozens of swords were pulled out of their hilts. They moved in unison and surrounded the corridor entrance by forming a crescent shape"

Crackle...!

Each knight was at least a mid to high-level sword expert. Their swords all contained sword auras and made menacing sounds. The knights glared at

Javier without an iota of mercy. They had blinding trust in their commander, Sir Kyle.

I knew it. It's because of this sword.

Javier smiled bitterly as he had seen this coming. He was actually prepared for this from the time he began to corner Sir Kyle at the end of the corridor. The sword in his hands belonged to the queen, and it didn't look good in front of others.

Though it's just pure chance that I have her sword...

But no one would trust him. They would rather place more trust in Sir Kyle's words since they were unaware of his betrayal.

But I don't care. The commander has already tried to kill the queen. It's likely that some of them may be on it with him. From now on, no one shall set foot here.

Javier positioned himself like a mountain. Iciness rolled off his body. His gaze was like that of a ferocious predator.

"I, Javier Asrahan, inquire by the entitlement granted to the knights. Come forth, those who are ready to abandon the vow made to Her Highness."

"What...?"

The knights flinched at Javier's words. Their faces turned dark. They couldn't believe what was coming out of the man who attempted to assassinate the queen and took over the corridor that led to the rest area.

"Do not listen to the traitor's nonsensical words. Strike him!"

Just then, Sir Kyle commanded aloud. This jostled the knights out of their confusion and got them to hurtle toward Javier.

"Ah!!!!"

The knights brandished their swords to protect the queen, aiming at the silver-haired assassin. But Javier remained wordless. He didn't even utter an excuse when unreasonable and irrational attacks showered him. Instead of confronting them with words, Javier decided to respond with this sword to clear the doubt, misunderstanding, and anger against him.

Crackle! Clang! Clang! Clang!

There were three knights charging at him together. Javier defended, kicked, and shoved the swords that flew at him in unison. He received head-on their wishes for death against him. Amid them, Javier coldly lifted his gaze and fixed it on one person. Sir Kyle. And Javier spoke with his eyes: Don't send these underdogs and fight for yourself. I have no intention of being subdued by these men. Javier's gaze made Sir Kyle's heart burn with emotion.

Fine. If that's what you want

Sir Kyle grinned. For the first time since the fight began, he had been granted the time to breathe and relax. A few breaths were all it took for him to restore his force, and his mana circulated in a manner distinct to sword masters. The sword in his hand glimmered until it finally started to burn.

Whoosh! An eerie radiance enveloped the silver blade. It was the ultimate weapon only a sword master could employ. Though it took a long time for it to get activated, nothing could stop it from slaying anything once it appeared. The aura sword emitted a ferocious glint like a predator's fang.

If you have decided this ground to be your grave, then I shall grant your wish.

Sir Kyle trudged in Javier's direction, his eyes loaded with icy animosity. He then lifted the blade charged with evil and jumped high, narrowing the distance between the two. *Leap!*

"…!"

The speed was incomparable to the previous one. A second was all it took for Sir Kyle to be two steps away from Javier. Sir Kyle flashed a grin as he

spotted Javier’s flaw.

“Got you.”

Swooosh! The force of the strong aura sword swept over Javier like a tsunami. Javier held out his sword at the same time and shot the mana blast. It clashed with the aura sword. Then, the tsunami split the blast.

“…!”

Swish! The aura sword that split the blast in half shredded Javier’s heart.

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Chapter 97: A Resplendent Resolution (1)

Crack! Zip! Something rough roared in his system. As he heard the sound, Lloyd thought to himself...

I had no idea how fatal poison could be until now.

It was nothing to joke about. Lloyd put his palm on the queen's stomach, and he absorbed the poison through it. The poison attacked his veins and tissue nonstop. Each time it happened, his muscle tissue and veins screamed aloud.

Crack! Crack! The poison tried to tear him apart, while his body resisted it. Caught between these two powers, Lloyd sweated in abundance. So, he endured all the more, harnessing more strength in the Asrahan Core Technique. The three circles fiercely rotated, sucking in the poison that invaded the queen's body.

"How did you... learn this?"

The queen gazed up at Lloyd. She had never experienced this mana absorption technique before. Her gaze was mixed with terror, wonder, curiosity, and adoration. The corners of Lloyd's lips rolled up bitterly.

"Um... Whew... If you talk now..."

"Should I stay quiet?"

"It makes it difficult for me to focus on your emergency treatment."

"But," reasoned the queen, "you absorb the poison very well, despite what you say."

"Well, if you accuse me of pretending, I have nothing to say," said Lloyd playfully as he maintained the Asrahan Core Technique. "Since you're asking, why doesn't Her Highness cheer me on so I can do a better job."

“Cheer? By the way, sucking out the poison will only put you in danger. Do you have any other plans in mind?” asked the queen.

“Of course I do. I should discharge it.”

“I see.”

The expression on the queen’s face softened a little, but Lloyd didn’t know whether it was because of the diminishing effect of the poison or because of his words that he had a plan in mind. Regardless, her gaze was still sharp.

“I have two more questions,” said the queen.

“Please do ask.”

“One. How did you figure out this was happening to rush in here?”

“I have excellent gut feelings.”

“Gut feelings?” asked the queen.

“Yes.”

“Be more specific.”

“Um, are you doubting me right now, Your Majesty?” asked Lloyd.

“Well, of course--”

“If I were on Kyle’s side, I wouldn’t be removing the poison out of your system, risking my life,” said Lloyd casually.

“...”

“I mean it, Your Highness. I came here because I overheard Sir Kyle talking with the Lord Great Chamberlain, and something stood out to me in their conversation.”

“What could have possibly stood out? What did he say to the Lord Great Chamberlain?” asked the queen.

“Something about,” explained Lloyd, “the banquet lasting until the moon sets.”

“It sounds innocuous to my ears. How was that strange?”

“It’s just a feeling. Their tone, gaze... They were dramatic.”

“Cheesy?”

“To be honest, Your Majesty, I never expected it to be treason. But...”

“But what? Do continue,” hurried the queen.

“I just thought that something fishy was going on between Sir Kyle and the Great Lord Chamberlain.”

“...”

“So, I figured that they would be a good source of entertainment and decided to trail behind them until I was met with this ruckus... Anyway, that’s how I came to be here.”

“It must not have been a pleasant sight.”

“No,” replied Lloyd.

For a moment, silence fell over them. Lloyd felt relieved in his heart.

Thankfully, the queen won’t be suspicious of me anymore.

The assassination attempt on the queen. Lloyd only predicted the incident because he had read the novel. The people in this world were clueless. The queen and the assassins didn’t know either. Only Lloyd knew about it because he had come across them in the novel.

So, I’m in the perfect spot to be suspected.

Lloyd had precipitously run up here to save the queen, but that gesture alone could seem suspicious. It signaled that Lloyd had noticed the circumstances of the assassin before anyone else did and that he had arrived at the scene earlier than everyone, minus the assassin. Those behaviors also warranted suspicion from others. Therefore, Lloyd needed to exonerate himself from these suspicions. He decided to be clever about it.

I'll mix the truth with a lie. Always works like a charm.

The truthful part was the code Sir Kyle had used before taking action. The lie was that Sir Kyle had a secret life. By mixing these two stories, Lloyd deprecated himself by admitting that he had arrived at this place after snooping around to enjoy some gossip. And now, he was risking his life and sucking poison out of the queen's body. These elements worked in synergy and cleared any doubt about him. The queen's gaze toward Lloyd softened.

"I see. But I have one more question," she said.

"Yes, Your Majesty. What is it?"

"Why is it that you are speaking more casually now?"

"Your Majesty...?"

"From the moment you set me down for emergency treatment, you started to be more casual, though very subtle, in addressing me. Was this intentional?" demanded the queen.

"Certainly not, Your Majesty."

"You just changed your tone faster than the wind blows."

"This is a misunderstanding, Your Highness."

"It appears not."

"I feel wronged, Your Majesty."

“How brazen of you,” she said as she softly chuckled. But she instantly put on a straight face again.

“By the way, Sir Asrahan, is it?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Do you think he will be fine? He is fighting against Sir Kyle.”

“...”

Lloyd clamped his mouth shut. He couldn’t answer her rashly. And, in fact, Javier was the reason why Lloyd was using all the strength he had to absorb the poison. He was trying to quickly finish administering the emergency treatment and go help Javier.

Javier hasn’t reached the level of a sword master.

And yet, Javier was forced to confront the sword master. Lloyd wondered how the fight ended. He could neither ascertain nor predict anything.

Of course, he won’t be defeated so easily. But that doesn’t mean I can relax right now.

Surely, Javier was a man of ingenious talent. He had already become a high-level sword expert and owned triple circles.

But even if he combines those two strengths, there will always be a gap he won’t be able to overcome against the sword master.

That was how terrifying sword masters were. The only ones that could stop a sword master were other masters. Their existence was likened to a strategic weapon, much like a nuclear weapon in the modern world. The number of sword masters in the land translated into military power for their respective countries.

And now, Javier is forced to fight against such a monstrous entity all by himself.

Of course, Javier became a sword master in the novel. He actually reached the level of grandmaster, advancing beyond the sword master level for the first time in history. But that was only in the novel. A totally different situation from where he was now. And if Javier got unlucky...

Javier could die.

Lloyd didn’t want to lose him here in vain. Javier had been a strong timber that supported him and was a sort of insurance for his future.

Ziiing!

Lloyd increased the rotating power of the circles by a notch. He was forced to his maximum limit. The poison absorbed by the queen started to stack up around the circles. However, he didn’t care.

Once I’m done absorbing the poison, I’ll eject it right away and run.

Then he’d go help Javier and fight alongside him. Beads of sweat dropped from Lloyd’s face, dripping on the queen’s face. But she could not rebuke him. The expression on Lloyd’s face as he focused on the Asrahan Core Technique appeared too grave.

The more I see him, the more amazed I get.

The construction of the suspension bridge was a first for her. Lloyd proved that his big talk wasn’t for show. He had the skills to prove he could do it. And now, the queen realized that he had been hiding his true abilities.

A technique to absorb external mana, other people’s mana, and special characteristics into himself. How clever. I had never imagined such a thing could happen.

But one such unimaginable event was taking place in real-time right in front of her. Poison was flowing out of her body. This was undeniable proof. That fact frightened and impressed the sword master.

I wonder what the limit is for this man.

She wanted to see if she could find out. She was intrigued. Curious. And just like that, the emergency treatment took place in the tranquil rest area as the queen stared up at Lloyd with curiosity in her eyes.

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Slash! The blast split in half, and the aura sword rushed forward to slash Javier in the chest. However, no blood splattered.

Hmm?

Sir Kyle's eyebrows trembled heavily. For a split second there, he had thought he slayed Javier. But when he brandished his sword, he realized that something felt light in his hands. The cut was minimal. As soon as Sir Kyle felt it, Javier attacked again like lightning.

Slash!

"…!"

There was no aura in Javier's sword, but it was as fast as light. Sir Kyle held up his sword.

Clang! Javier's sword bounced off the aura sword. The shockwave allowed Sir Kyle a glimpse of what had happened.

I only cut his clothes.

He stared at the front of Javier's clothes. They were vertically torn, and the gap exposed Javier's chest.

Such amazing speed.

A pure sense of admiration gripped Sir Kyle. When he had slashed Javier's mana blast in half and used the momentum to slay his chest, Sir Kyle was convinced that he would get the better of Javier. But he was wrong.

He's strong and fast, even though he isn't a sword master. Technique-wise, he might be equal to me, or even better.

The silver-haired fledgling appeared to be just over 20 years old. But he was monstrously talented. Sir Kyle could already picture what would happen if he rose to the level of a sword master.

He's going to easily surpass me.

He had to admit it. At the same time, a violent impulse took over him.

But that won't ever happen. Why? Because he'll die right here.

A sense of pleasure rushed through Sir Kyle at the thought of nipping the sprouts of a talented rival and trampling him. This violent impulse made the corners of his lips rise upward. The muscles in his hands tightened as he gripped his sword.

I'll make sure that you die today. Resist all you want!

He brimmed with confidence, as he held an aura sword. He had nothing to fear anymore.

Whoosh! Clack! Sir Kyle raised his sword at a strange angle. The aura burning fiery in the sword rushed toward Javier.

Clang!

The aura and Javier's sword clashed, instantly breaking a piece of the latter's blade. It got torn and shattered by the aura. Javier's face darkened while Sir Kyle scoffed.

"Do you think you can defend against an aura sword at your level?"

Crash! The aura sword struck down once more. Javier's sword began to shatter into pieces with the blow, which deepened Sir Kyle's mocking laughter.

"You blocked me again? I must say, you have my praise for keeping your sword in one piece even after you blocked mine."

Slash! The aura sword was brought down one more time. Another side of Javier's blade crashed, and this time, Sir Kyle's smile mixed with deathly desire.

"Woah. Three blocks? I suppose it's because it's the queen's sword. What do you say about using your skills from before?"

"..."

Javier couldn't answer because he didn't have the energy or time to do so. The moment he first blocked the aura sword, his whole stomach churned, the impact turning his system upside down. It felt as though he was using his fingers to block a giant's hammer. He wasn't spared a second to use the Asrahan Core Technique and absorb the mana. Each time he blocked, each massive blow accumulated inside his system, paralyzing his legs. They refused to move, frozen by the building force.

Use the mana blast, maybe?

The thought crossed his mind. But he knew that the mana blast wasn't enough. And besides, it had already split in half a while ago by the aura sword. And if he used it once more, it'd surely mean a slice to his chest, not his clothing.

I wish I was a sword master.

He would have easily neutralized the aura sword if he was a sword master with his mana blast. No, he wouldn't need to use the skill in the first place since he would have an aura sword like his opponent.

Master... Lloyd.

Crash! Another blow struck down again, making him feel like he had become a stake stuck in the earth.

Cough! Blood came out as Javier coughed. The rotation of his circles slowed. For the fifth time, a merciless impact struck down like lightning.

Crack!

“…!”

At last, the queen’s sword broke in half, the aura sword charging down at Javier as a result.

It can’t end like this!

One second. Javier told himself that he should stall by at least a second. That was how he could increase Lloyd’s chances of treating the queen and surviving. Since the queen was a sword master, she would be able to put up a fight against Sir Kyle.

Argh!

Javier decided to put his pride aside to stall his death by even a second. He fell to the ground and slid to the side. *Slash!*

The aura sword scratched the ground, sparks bursting in all directions. Javier managed to avoid death by a split second. He resolved to buy some more time, so he wielded his half-cut sword in the hopes to increase the chances of Lloyd making it out alive. Just then, a merciless kick knocked him in the stomach. *Slam!*

“…!”

The kick smashed against his chest and sent him nine steps backward into the corridor. His body crashed into the table in the corner and flopped to the ground.

Crack! Flop!

Splinters of wood littered the ground. Javier raised his body in the rubble.

I’m not done yet.

He didn’t give up. He held out his hand and grabbed the leg of the broken table. Sir Kyle, who had hurtled toward him when he rose, was near him now.

Striking down the burning aura sword, Sir Kyle hollered, “It’s over now!”

Fwoosh! The aura sword came down like a bolt of lightning. Javier raised the table leg. Sir Kyle flashed a smile. There was only one thing that could stop his aura sword: another aura sword. This law was absolute.

How dare he block my aura sword with a table leg! Ha! Struggle all you want!

Just then... *Thwack!*

The aura sword was blocked by the piece of wood.

“Huh?”

What’s happening?

Sir Kyle’s eyes snapped open. Just then, something unprecedented started to take place with the table leg.

Crackle...! Cold rays of light appeared in streaks, enveloping the table leg with fierce radiance. It was the brilliant determination only those who reached the master level of swordsmanship could muster. The aura.

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Chapter 98: A Resplendent Resolution (2)

Thwack! Memories always hurt. The plume of smoke burning overhead. The corpses on the ground. Mother lay still. Father lost focus in his eyes. Javier grabbed, shoved, and shook their shoulders. But there was no response. Not even a smile.

Thwack! The impact shook his shoulders. The impact stirred memories in him. The shout outside the barn. Something seemed to be in there! He rose the moment he heard the shout, crawling and rolling into a stack of hay in the barn. There inside the compact and musty pile of hay, Javier made a resolution. He owed his life to his parents, so he would make it worth it. He would live so that one day, he could choose the place he would take his last breath for himself.

Thwack! The impact hit his shoulders again. Javier opened his eyes amid the shock, being jostled out of the memory of when he was five years old, hiding in the pile of hay. He was now 21 years old. He lifted his head, and his eyes saw the flustered face of his enemy.

“What...”

The ferocious radiance illuminated his enemy’s face. The brilliant resolution enveloped the table leg. Javier noticed the aura in the table leg in his hand. But it wasn’t just the block of wood. His hand, wrist, arms, shoulders, and heart glimmered with the aura.

Thump...! Thump! His unprecedented resolution wrapped his heart, tapping into and opening a firm manaheart. Like the groan of a giant carrying the sky, the manaheart split and spread away. Destruction for regeneration. Death for resurrection. Breakage and recomposition. Perishing and being born. It split and spread, only to gather, connect, and breathe. The beginning and the end circulated. The beginning called the ending. In between the attractions and at the end of the balanced destruction and regeneration of chaos. The heart of the beginning pumped like his resolution from his memory.

Thud! The newly generated mana heart beat for the first time. A different force tapped his blood vessels awake. They pumped as it spread to all corners of his body, raving and seeping into himself. Every cell reacted. The mana circulated without an end, which was only possible for sword masters. Javier moved amid it.

Thwack!

"...!"

He wielded the table leg, and the aura wrapped around it reacted on its own as though it was a living beast going after its prey. Each ray of aura sharpened the blade and discharged an insurmountable, raging force, following the trajectory of the table leg. It then bounced off the sword Sir Kyle was slamming down.

Clash! As the sword bounced off, Sir Kyle's eyes flew open in terror.

What's happening?!

He couldn't wrap his head around what was happening right now. Why was there an aura in the table leg in that boy's hand? How was it possible to produce aura through an object like a table leg? Amid the curiosity, shock, and disbelief, he closely managed to grasp his sword back. He pulled it to his side, feeling a sense of crisis, and defended the left top by instinct.

Wham! Javier's table leg came down at him, and its aura gushed out as if it was a fang of a predator.

"Argh...!"

He almost failed to block it. And even though it was just one sword strike, his waist staggered, and he almost keeled over.

No way!

He jumped back in alarm. He couldn't believe it. The aura loaded in a mere splinter of wood made him retreat.

This is a lie. A scam!

Grit! Sir Kyle felt as though his world was crumbling to pieces. A sense of shame surged in him as his pride was shredded to pieces. Sir Kyle gritted his teeth and gripped his sword tighter. Who was he? A genius swordsman. A human weapon. A strategic arsenal.

I need to regain my footing first.

Sir Kyle took a breath, and that alone controlled his emotions enough. His heart was no longer feeling flustered. He shoved the shock and terror to the side and focused on the enemy in front of him after pulling himself together. And with a cold, icy gaze, he studied his opponent.

Slash!

The table leg was coming at him, and the aura formed in streaks following the trajectory.

Admit it. He's become a sword master as well.

That was an aura, for sure. He had to admit it so that he could come up with a stronger aura to fight back and crush it. That would be his best shot at defeating this silver-haired, monstrously talented novice. His eyes burned with determination.

Exhale! Grit!

It was time for a head-on fight. Sir Kyle hurtled with such resolution and harnessed every bit of his mana into his sword. And there, he brandished the sword with all the aura he could muster.

There is no way I will lose in an aura-on-aura fight!

He had years more of experience as a sword master. He had to be better by several folds when it came to the power of the aura and his skills. He believed in himself and came up with a surefire method.

Suppress him in an aura sword fight, slice the table leg, and use the momentum to take his head next!

Slash! Sir Kyle's aura sword. Javier's aura table leg. The fangs of the two beasts collided.

Clash! The sword broke into dozens of pieces, and some of them stabbed Sir Kyle's body.

"...!"

Sir Kyle didn't have the time to scream or feel pain.

How?

The moment his brain formed a question in terror, he saw Javier's table leg flash with light. Then, it came down on his right shoulder like a streak of lightning.

Slash! Blood splattered. Sir Kyle's amputated right arm flew in the air with his sword still in its grip. It fell to the ground, the blood drawing a pool of red, staining the white marble.

"Argh...!"

Sir Kyle grimaced in pain, but before he could wrap the injury, Javier mercilessly kicked him in the gut. *Bam!*

"...!"

His nose got smashed, and he staggered and collapsed to the ground. But before he hit the ground, Javier grabbed the back of his neck and steadied his limp body.

"Anybody takes a step forward, and I shall slice his neck."

Javier's icy voice rang aloud in the room. That was when it occurred to Sir Kyle what kind of sorrowful state he found himself in.

Could this be true...? Could it be that I've been taken hostage?

Sir Kyle's trembling eyes stared straight ahead. The banquet hall came into view. The noble women clamped their mouths with their hands, holding their screams. The nobles, drained of color, protected their noble wives. The royal guards flinched with swords in their hands, all flustered. Then, he looked down at himself. A hostage without a right arm, whose neck was being gripped by the mewling silver-haired boy.

Whoosh... He suddenly felt the table leg on his shoulder. Its aura licked his right earlobe to his terror. That was when he had a realization. He had lost. He had become a hostage. Any struggle and he would get beheaded.

I... lost to this boy...? Argh...

Sir Kyle's face fell at last, along with the pride he held so dearly. But Javier didn't care in the least about his despair. Javier simply stared at the royal guards as he took steps toward the entrance of the corridor. At that moment, he smiled wryly.

Out of all the people in here, this one had to be my hostage.

It was ironic that the person Javier held hostage to protect the queen was her would-be assassin. But he didn't care. His most important mission right now was to ensure that no one would step foot in the rest area. There may be a traitor among the guards. Javier couldn't trust anyone, so he made sure that no one passed him.

Master Lloyd... May what you are doing end in success...

He wished that Lloyd would save the queen. He hoped and waited faithfully, and just as Lloyd got involved in this case through his trust in Javier, the same thing would be done for him. Javier would guard this place due to his trust in Lloyd. Javier's gaze suppressed everyone with its hostility. The new sword master. The royal guards could do nothing but lower their swords in the face of his overwhelming might.

***

Ziiing...!

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 4: Circle Shift has been activated.]

[All the circles are set to gear six. Fixed at RPM 6,000.]

Hmph!

The rest area was quiet. Beads of sweat dripped from Lloyd's face. The circle rotated at high speed around his heart, creating a strong absorption power and wrapping the poison around his organ.

It's almost done.

The volume and potency of the poison he absorbed from the queen was no laughing matter.

One mistake, and it'll spread all over my body.

If that happened, he would die for sure. He could ascertain as the poison felt potent even though he was feeling it indirectly.

The moment it spreads, it's going to block all my nerves and melt their surrounding tissue.

It'd inflict comprehensive damage to his tissue, and large blood clots would block his blood flow, putting a halt to the oxygen supply in his body. Once that happened, all his organs would stop functioning, and he would fall into shock.

I must never lower the circle rotation power.

Lloyd stayed vigilant, never letting his guard down. He was like a poison-filled bucket going around at full speed. As long as it kept spinning, the centrifugal force would be maintained and keep the poison in check. But once it weakened, the rotation would slow down and make the poison burst out of the bucket as there would be no centrifugal force. It would cover him, and he would surely die as a result.

So, these three circles act like a bucket. Okay, I'm done.

Ziiing! The circles continued spinning, and now, no poison could be absorbed. It was finished.

"Okay. It's done, my dear client, no, Your Highness..."

Lloyd slowly rose lest the circles' rotations lose their speed. Like a sleepy sloth, he measured his steps and walked away from the queen.

The absorption is done. It's time to safely discharge it.

He spotted the wine bottle he had already eyed a while ago. Grabbing the wine bottle, he pulled the cork out and emptied the bottle. Then, he stuck his right index finger into the opening.

If I boil down the poison, I'd have about five drops.

He estimated the actual amount of the poison going rampant in the trap of his circles. He concentrated his mind, measuring his breath.

Zing! Keeping the rotation power intact, he shifted the direction. From collection to purification. From absorption to discharge. He took the steps opposite to what he had been taking. And he failed.

Thwack!

"Ack...!"

Lloyd reflexively clutched his heart, which was wracked with excruciating pain that seemed to squeeze it until it burst. Everything turned black at the massive pain, and he almost stopped the Circle Shift.

What the heck? What is this?

He was confused. He had done everything he normally did. Absorb the external energy and discharge it. He had simply followed his usual procedure.

Why can’t I discharge it?

The poison could not be released. It instead stuck to the circle like a sticky oil residue. It was glued to the rotating circle. This was something he was experiencing for the first time. He was scared.

What should I do?

Time wasn’t on Lloyd’s side. The poison continued to stick more and more to the circle with great tenacity even while he racked his brain for a solution. The circle slowed its rotation.

Ding Dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 4: Something is interrupting the movement of the Circle Shift.]

[Due to the powerful external interruption, the maximum rotation number of the Circle Shift will be limited to five.]

[All the circles are set to gear five by force. Fixed at RPM 5,000.]

Crack... Crack!

Making things worse, the circle gear was forcefully decreased to five. This meant that the RPM was now at a 5/6 level compared to the previous one. And the poison trapped in the rotation power became more reactive and violent. It was like a beast that wanted to break through its cage and run free.

Dammit.

His heart sank. This was not a joke. The gear would continue to decrease if he didn’t respond quickly. The poison would be freed to roam around inside him.

Like I’d let that happen!

It was time for a full-out brainstorming session. Possibilities and hope. Trials and results. Lloyd reviewed all the scenarios in the twinkle of his eye. Inspection. Calculation. His anxiety must have been written all over his face because the queen, all pale and white, rose and staggered to his side.

“Is something going wrong?”

“...”

Lloyd didn’t have the time to respond to her. Her face turned serious.

“Can you not get the poison you absorbed out of your system?”

“...”

He barely nodded. The queen’s gaze turned stern.

“Can you transfer the poison into one arm?”

“...”

He could. But he didn’t want to. *The Knight of Blood and Iron* came to his mind. In the novel, the queen treated herself by concentrating the poison in her arm and cutting it off. That was how she lost her left arm.

No thank you.

He rejected her with his gaze, hinting that she should back off.

Cutting off my arm is just too drastic of a solution.

Any method that damaged him was overruled. No questions. He’d rather put himself in a do-or-die situation, which he was about to do now.

Whew...

He breathed in, and he faced the opposite side of the queen. Just then, an ominous message floated in front of his eyes.

Ding Dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 4: Something is interrupting the movement of the Circle Shift.]

[Due to the powerful external interruption, the maximum rotation number of the Circle Shift will be limited to four.]

[All the circles are set to gear four by force. Fixed at RPM 4,000.]

Thud! The rotation of the circle received greater resistance. Now, the circles rotated like cogwheels caught in a swamp. The force of the poison started to creep outside the rotation's power as it weakened. A beast in a crumbling cage. Feeling the terror of its movement, Lloyd held out his hand and grabbed the dining knife on the table.

Grip! One shot. Clean and cut. Lloyd adjusted the gear shift.

2:3:3.

Ziiing! The alpha circle was set to 2,000 RPM while the others were set to 3,000 RPM. As Lloyd lowered the rotation power, the poison finally broke the cage and rushed outside, making its way toward his heart. Just then, the three circles reverberated in the rotation ratio of 2:3:3. They pulled each other and grabbed the nape of the poison. Then, they collided.

Boom! Lloyd's outstretched knife shot a ferocious storm of mana from its silvery end. This was his best bet for getting the poison out of his system. The triple mana blast.

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Chapter 99: The Night of Compliments (1)

Boom! The three fragments of the circles collided, causing a massive explosion around Lloyd's heart.

[Manaheart Skill Option 1: Shock Neutralizer has been activated.]

[Your manaheart can neutralize the impact of the mana blast on its own without the protection of the circles. Therefore, your manaheart does not get any damage from the mana blast.]

Clack! Click!

The manaheart became solid, and it absorbed the impact of the mana blast. There wasn't any damage left. Instead, the entire force shot toward the outside. *Fwoosh!*

The blast supercharged along the blood vessel, lymph nodes, and muscle tissues. It traveled along the path Lloyd led. Some rushed out of the heart to the pectoral muscle and pectoralis minor muscle. The others split and combined to travel through the trapezius muscle, roofing cuff, deltoid, and coracobrachialis. And after it passed the vein in the wrist, it penetrated the ligaments and joints until it exploded from the tip of the knife in his hand.

Crash! The large pillar of fire of the triple mana blast shot diagonally. The violent fire created by the collision of pure mana burned everything that stood its way. It cut, melted, incinerated, and obliterated the closet, the wall, and the ceiling. The poison that ran rampant to be freed from the clutches of the circle disappeared as well.

I did it!

Lloyd's eyes glimmered as he shot out the mana blast with his knife. He had a feeling he would succeed as he intentionally lowered the spinning power of the circles while activating the Circle Shift. His senses picked up the poison trying to slip out of the spin when they slowed down. That was when Lloyd made all three circles collide, right before the venom finally escaped

and entered his system. The collision engulfed the poison, and the explosion was so strong that the venom didn’t stand a chance against it. Like a cat falling into a rapid current of water, it flailed and struggled with its paws to get on land. But it didn’t work. The force of the triple mana blast was overwhelmingly strong. And at last, it got expelled out of him through the knife into the air, carried by the explosive blast and exposed to the immense force in the air.

Crackle! A considerable part of the force discharged in the blast was consumed by heat energy. The extreme heat burned and scorched the toxic substance, and the protein in the poison became altered. The link of the molecules snapped and broke. They changed in shape and color. Unable to hold up against heat, it finally became carbonized.

Fwoosh... The toxic substance was lost in the fiery heat. But the force of the triple mana blast remained indomitable and powerful nonetheless. It flew ahead with much violence, penetrating the 6-foot-wide roof and many other things that were in front of it. Once it pierced everything, and nothing stood in its way, it shot into the night sky.

Fwoosh! The fire pillar of the mana shot up about 75 yards in the air, allowing anyone in the capital to see its magnificence. As the people laid their eyes on it with panic, the pillar soon subsided.

Cough! Cough! Cough!”

The triple mana blast left a heavy toll on the body. Even though the heart was protected from damage, that wasn’t the end of it.

Ugh. I feel like my whole body was crushed down to the bones.

Every bit of his body was sore and throbbed as though it was beaten down with a hammer. Though the blast lasted only for a moment, it nonetheless was unbearably strong for a human body. And now, the manaheart had been emptied. Lloyd felt both terribly fatigued and like he caught the flu. His legs gave way, and he collapsed to the floor.

This is seriously no joke.

It wasn’t this bad when he had used the triple mana blast to lay down the basic foundation of the suspension bridge. But this time was different as he had exhausted all his energy to save his life. That made a larger difference than he had expected. Even so, he didn’t pass out from the pain, although, in all honesty, he wanted to. There was a reason why he didn’t allow himself to faint, and that was because of the message that floated in front of him.

Ding Dong.

[You have survived despite the fact that your body was invaded by a large amount of Lunatica, a fatal poison.]

[In the process, you have succeeded in expelling the poison in an impressive manner.]

[For your special experience, two of your skills have been equipped with a unique upgrade.]

Unique upgrade? Wait a minute... Optional Skills?

Lloyd dropped to the ground in sheer exhaustion. But what looked like an alert for an award dinged in front of him. He didn’t want to miss it by passing out. He would wake up again in curiosity even if he did. His eyes started quickly moving.

[New skill options have been made available in the manaheart skill.]

[Skill Option 2: Complete Poison Resistance - You have survived despite the powerful compound toxic “Lunatica.” For your experience, a permanent poison immunity has been added to your manaheart. This option will enable you to become highly resistant to all types of poison existing on the land.]”

[New skill options have been made available in the Asrahan Core Technique skill.]

[Skill Option 2: Supercharge - The skill accelerates the recovery of mana when extreme depletion occurs. Once you use the option, one of the circles

rotates at a high speed for five minutes and absorbs a large amount of mana from your surroundings. Limit: You can only use this once per day.]

Ha? Hahaha.

A grin spread across Lloyd's face as he read the message. These upgrades were entirely uncalled for.

All I did was desperately try to make it out alive.

That was all he did. He tried everything he could possibly think of, but nothing expelled the poison from him. Nothing changed regardless of how he spun the circle. He even thought about using the Latent Power Surge of the Asrahan Core Technique.

But if I failed, that would've been it for me. The Asrahan Core Technique can't be used when I'm exhausted. After all, the circle stops spinning when that happens."

Should the circles have stopped spinning, the poison would have spilled out into his system and killed him right there. Thus, he reached the decision that the mana blast was the solution. He gave everything he had thinking so. And now, he bore the unexpected fruits that were the optional skills.

Complete immunity to poison. Well, there goes my worry of being poisoned to death in my life. I love it. And Supercharge? Hmm... I suppose I got this because I didn't pass out even after I emptied out all my mana with the triple mana blast."

Lloyd thoroughly read over the optional skill of Supercharge.

Random absorption of mana in my surroundings?

Absorbing mana was the main goal and foundation of the Asrahan Core Technique. And this optional skill looked like it enabled the basic function to its extreme.

Let's try it out then.

He was already depleted of mana anyway. Standing up was labor for him. He would pass out if he loosened up. So, there was no time better than now to test out the Supercharge skill.

Let’s give it a try.

He opened the skill window and activated the optional skill.

Ding Dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 5: Supercharge has been activated.]

[You are absorbing a large amount of mana from random surroundings.]

From then on...

Ziiing... The three circles started after having been left quiet by the collision of the triple mana blast. It was like turning on a fan that had been stashed in a garage all winter long. At first, they made a clunking noise until they started to rotate. The rotation grew smoother, faster, and fiercer. It surpassed the normal limit. From the soft wind, it grew stronger, summoning a storm.

Ziiing! As the circle roared and rotated in three parts, it formed into a vortex with an impressive absorption power. As though it was a black hole, the vortex started to suck the mana around it.

Clank! Clink! There was no one except for the queen and Lloyd, but the table tumbled. Lloyd absorbed a small amount of mana laden in the mahogany wood. It started to crumble. The same thing happened to the others. The rose on the table wilted in a trice, and the springtail crawling behind the makeup table immediately dried up. Even the marble started to lose its gloss. There were no exceptions made for any people as well.

“What... are you doing right now?”

Queen Magentano’s voice quaked in fear. She dropped to the ground just like Lloyd did after being poisoned. Needless to say, her body was in a terrible state as she witnessed the triple mana blast that shot out Lloyd. She

had never seen such a thing before, nor did she ever imagine it would be possible. It came to her as a complete shock that such massive power could be released with just pure mana, not magic.

I have never fathomed once in my life that this could be possible.

But it did happen right in front of her, and by Lloyd, who wasn't even a sword master. If there was one thing that could harness such powerful force purely with mana, it was an aura. The explosion Lloyd showed to her bragged an overwhelming force that would neutralize an aura. Her understanding of the world shattered at that instant. But before she could recover, another wave of shock came to frighten her once more.

"My mana is... Argh!"

Her mana was being taken by no other than Lloyd, who was on the ground five steps away from her! Queen Magentano hurriedly activated her manaheart.

"Arggh!"

Sink! Crash! She forcibly moved her exhausted manaheart. Otherwise, she feared that she would be sucked to dry and die from excessive mana loss.

Thud! Thud! Her heart pounded visibly, and the mana in her system circulated in harmony, which was something only sword masters could do. This method was also the secret behind gaining endless endurance in battles.

Regardless... I'm losing just a little more mana than I can handle. Argh...

But thankfully, it wasn't strong enough to kill her. Although, it was more than able to nauseate her. And since she had to maintain the circulation of the mana in her body, she couldn't speak at all. The mana absorption forced her to put all her energy into replenishing her body again, and ironically, her strained efforts became an excellent help for Lloyd.

Ziiing! Lloyd absorbed an alarming of mana with each second that passed. He was a mana blackhole. Falling into a state of stupor, he devoured the mana around him, especially from the queen.

Whew...

Lloyd breathed in and out, searching for the purest and most refined mana by instinct. He yearned, usurped, and absorbed it to make it his. The source was the queen, who was the sword master. Hers contained the refined power that was brought about after a strenuous mana circulation. It was different from the mana permeating in nature in terms of its density and purity. The difference was truly immense. The mana in nature was just an ordinary atom, while the refined mana of Queen Magentano was a hard-compressed neutron star. If applied, the compression would reduce the Empire State Building in the United States to a tiny millet. That was the power of the mana Lloyd was absorbing from the queen. Her mana's density and purity commanded awe, and it was entirely different from what came from nature. Such high-quality mana filled Lloyd's empty manaheart. No, it did more than fill it. It burst in full, forcibly expanding its storage. Lloyd's manaheart underwent an evolution.

Ding Dong. Ding Dong.

Countless messages appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes, which were still in the state of stupor. The manaheart's skill experience continued to rise over its limit. As its experience continued to stack up, his level increased without any show of rest. The level-up messages popped up one after another. As Lloyd absorbed more mana, Queen Magentano's face grew pale.

Gah... I didn't think this would be possible...

She never did. It felt like her world had turned upside down. But she had no time to ask questions or energy to walk over to Lloyd. She would have to surrender more mana to him if she did. So, she desperately struggled to stay away from Lloyd. That, unfortunately, didn't happen as much as she wished. Moving even an inch proved to be a toil. All she could do was become a portable charger for Lloyd's manaheart.

This can’t be real!

Queen Magentano gave all her efforts to retain as much as mana in her. Every fiber of her being strove to resist the pilfering. But it was in vain. As Lloyd leveled up his manaheart, the amount of mana he absorbed increased. It was a natural occurrence. There was more room for mana in his manaheart as it tore and expanded. Lloyd unreservedly stole mana from her, continuing the unfair tug of war. If the queen was a high-level sword expert, she would have been depleted of mana already and become a mummy. But thankfully, she was a sword master, which meant that she could resist by circulating the mana in her instead of ending up as a bloodless corpse. Lloyd enjoyed the infinite flow of mana as well, thanks to that. Supposedly, the Supercharge was meant to absorb some energy present in nature to gain some strength just enough to get him back on his feet. But when it was used against a sword master, it went beyond, and she became a source of nutrients for an explosive power-up. Lloyd’s manaheart continued to be filled, and it tore and expanded on repeat. He continued leveling up without stopping, from two to three, from four to five. In no time, he reached level ten. And when he reached level 11, which took him just five minutes when others would have taken several years, an eye-catching message dinged in front of him.

[Skill Class Level Up!]

[Your Manaheart skill level has risen to the rank of <Low Level Sword Expert>!]

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Chapter 100: The Night of Compliments (2)

[Skill Class Level Up!]

[Your Manaheart skill level has risen to the rank of <Low-Level Sword Expert>.]

A message floated in front of his eyes, but Lloyd remained in a state of stupor. His eyes were open, but nothing was processed. He remained in a sitting position with his focus resting solely on his inward thoughts.

Ziiing! The manaheart was packed with three rotating circles, and the mana boasting amazing density and purity flowed into him through them. This experience shocked Lloyd.

Whew!

A piece. A breath. Even when that small amount of mana entered his system, his manaheart tumbled in tumult, making him feel like he was a teacup inside a storm or a bucket catching the ocean. He couldn’t take the inflow of mana that came in violent waves. He could only take a tiny portion of the whole, and that alone ripped apart his manaheart. Clash!

Ack!

A searing pain shot through his body as his mana ripped to pieces. But at the same time, he felt refreshed as everything was destroyed and disbanded, only to be put together and regenerated. In no time, his manaheart was restored, stronger and better than it was previously. He could take a bit more mana. But the influx of mana from the queen remained overwhelming and ripped apart his manaheart again. Just like that, his regenerated mana heart was ripped apart and shattered over and over again. It was restored only to be torn, and then, regenerated once more. The cycle of endless destruction and revival. Lloyd sweated like a horse. Black droplets of sweats seeped out of his pores. It was the result of the dark and clouded energy that accumulated in his body throughout his life. And when the

powerful mana of the sword master made its way into his system, it pushed and discharged the clouded energy out of him.

Argh...

His whole body shook, but he endured in his stupor. Five minutes, which felt like unbearable torture, passed. And at last, the three circles, which were going berserk like a black hole, quieted down.

Ziiing... Their rotation slowed, and the devouring absorption stopped. The result was tremendously wretched for those around Lloyd. Everything around him within a 200 feet distance was far from okay. The table dried up and crumbled to dust. The chair beside it met the same fate. The rose as well as the bugs in it had disappeared without a trace. Any metal objects were covered in rust, and the bricks for the walls and ceilings turned soft. Within the distance, the only one that had remained safe was Queen Magentano.

“Huff...!! Huff!”

Is it finally over? He is not going to start again, is he? He must not. I am not confident that I can endure another round.

Queen Magentano, who was pale as a sheet, lifted her head after a struggle. The mana absorption was heinous. She felt proud that she had survived the storm.

Even a mid-level sword expert, no, a high-level sword expert wouldn’t have survived.

You would lose all your mana and be drained of life eventually, dying all dried up and bloodless like a mummy. The thought of it made her break out in a cold sweat.

Goodness... What kind of technique is this...

Her trembling eyes traveled to Lloyd. He was calmly sitting at the center of the heinous mana vortex. She saw his eyes slowly open. Black like always.

But she noticed that his gaze shone and sparkled after being cleansed of the dark energy it held before.

Oh.

It was only then that Lloyd was able to see the message in front of him.

What is this...?

Ding Dong.

[Skill Class Level Up!]

[Skill Name: Manaheart.]

[Stage: Low-Level Sword Expert Lv. 1]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 300%]

[Current Inventory of Optional Skills: ① Shock Neutralizer / ② Complete Immunity to Poison]

[Required RP to level up: 300]

[Your Manaheart skill level has risen to the rank of <Low-Level Sword Expert>.]

[Your manaheart has undergone exponential growth amid the confusion by chance. For this special experience, your skill has gained new upgrades.]

[Skill Option 3: Frenzy - You will fall into a state of frenzy for 60 seconds. When it’s on, you will blindly move toward the target designated prior to activating the option. During this time, all pain will be numbed, and you will never faint. Your strength, stamina, and reflexes will be increased by 200%. (Limit: You can only use this once per day.)]

[Current RP: 4,029]

What the heck is this?

Dazed, Lloyd's eyes widened. He was happy and flustered at the same time. It was only natural since all he did was activate the Supercharge optional skill of the Asrahan Core Technique. Why? This new optional skill seemed appropriate to use in this situation and testing it out seemed like a good choice. So, he tried it out, closed his eyes, and fell into a stupor. He felt like his eyes were closed only for a few seconds. And when he opened them, he had become a low-level sword expert!

It’s been five minutes already? But even so, how is it possible that I became a low-level sword expert even after that? He couldn’t believe it. But he couldn’t deny the change in him when his surroundings were reduced to ashes. The table and chair were crumbled to pieces. The metal adornments had grown rusty. The bricks had softened. The carpet was faded as if it was 100 years old. Lloyd’s gaze traveled to the queen, who was despairingly looking at him about five feet away from him.

“You... You... What are you?”

Queen Magentano was stuttering, unlike her. Her face looked worse than a while ago. She wasn’t this pale when the poison was killing her. Right now, her skin was so white that she looked like a terminally ill person who had never received sunlight for a whole year.

Did I do that to her?

It looked like it. The description of the Supercharge skill in the message seemed to agree as well.

Yeah. It said that the skill absorbs all the surrounding mana in large amounts without discrimination.

But he had no idea that it would be this annihilating. The suction of the mana occurred with an unimaginable force. This made Lloyd embarrassed for a second, but he soon brushed it away because that was not what mattered right now. The queen was now healed from the poison, and he was alive. It was time to go help Javier.

Javier is up against a sword master.

Lloyd was worried even if Javier had a God-given talent. His opponent was Sir Kyle, the sword master. Lloyd couldn’t imagine how Javier would last against a knight of such caliber. If he was unlucky, he could have already lost.

I hope that didn’t happen. Please.

Lloyd bolted up in anxiousness. Thankfully, his leg didn’t give way. He was rather energized from rising to the level of a low-level sword expert. Lloyd quickly supported the queen.

“Your Majesty, is your body all right?”

“Do I look all right in your eyes?”

“...”

“I shall ask again. What are you? What did you just do?”

The queen’s gaze was filled with suspicion. It traveled to the hole in the ceiling that showed the night sky. And then it moved downward.

“I have never heard of those techniques you displayed earlier... the discharge of explosive mana and the rapid absorption of my mana...”

“Indeed, Your Majesty.”

“Can you explain what they were?”

“Why, yes, Your Majesty. However, may I plead that we have this conversation later?”

“Is it because of Sir Asrahan, the knight of yours?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Is it because you are worried about him?”

“I wish to move at once and help him,” Lloyd said with confidence.

“I am of the same heart. Let us move. Can you carry me on your back?” the queen asked.

“It is my honor.”

Lloyd then turned backward, and the queen got on his back right away.

“I shall run now,” Lloyd said, and without waiting for her response, he sprinted.

Swoosh! His steps were faster than before, and using the energy in him, he rushed out of the rest area. He sprinted along the long corridor, direly wishing for Javier’s safety. He planned to join the fight right away the moment he arrived at the banquet hall. He would stand side by side with Javier and fight against Sir Kyle.

I will be able to help out since I have become a low-level sword expert.

Plus, he owned a triple circle. If things went wrong, he could always bazooka the knight with his triple mana blast. And though the chances of him getting heavily injured were slim, it could happen given that he had little knowledge about his skill.

So just hold up a little more!

Jump! Sprint! Lloyd passed the passage lit by a dancing chandelier. He turned the corner and jumped off the stairs. Meanwhile, the queen focused on recuperating on Lloyd’s back.

Good. Just a little more.

The queen was still circulating her mana. A skill unique to sword masters. Thanks to being carried by Lloyd, her face recovered color, and she looked much better. Her exhausted muscles were vitalized once again.

About one-third of my power has been recovered.

Surely, it wasn’t satisfactory. But it was enough to put up a fight. And since she was with Javier, Lloyd, and the other knights present in the hall, she

believed that Sir Kyle would be easily defeated.

Sir Kyle.

Her eyes burned with sad rage. He was the longest-standing commander of the knights. He was her sword teacher, her most trusted subject. But today, he was the traitor that laid a sword on her neck.

Why? Why did he do it?

She couldn’t wrap her head around his reason for betrayal and who was behind this. Her venomous efforts to pinpoint it failed. Every suspicion and fact was like shards of glass scattered in thick clouds. The more she thought about it, the more determined she became.

Sir Kyle. I shall never let you off the hook. Your death shall never come so easily. Every scheme of yours, and the people behind you shall be revealed.

Only after then would the queen behead him.

That will be my farewell to the subject I once cherished.

Grit! Deathly rage. Icy coldness. The queen’s shoulders trembled as such emotions surged in her. At the same time, she prepared herself for the bloody battle soon to take place in a moment. Just then, Lloyd, who was running the corridor, took a final turn.

Leap!

“Huh?”

Lloyd flinched in surprise as he ran, stopping dead in his tracks. He looked ahead.

“Javier?”

His gaze lay at the exit of the corridor, where a man was standing with his back facing Lloyd. The chandelier brightly lit up the banquet hall, and several long swords glinted against the light. The brilliant lights blinded

Lloyd, so he could only see the outline of the figure. However, he could still recognize who it was nonetheless.

“Javier. Are you all right?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

Javier turned to his side. There was a smile on his face. Lloyd meant to scold him for smiling in such a grave situation. He was about to until he was forced to clamp his mouth shut. Right before the words of rebuke came out, Lloyd’s eyes saw the outline of a man whose body lay limp in Javier’s hands. The outline was familiar to Lloyd’s eyes as well.

Could it be...?

Lloyd thought it was impossible. He blinked several times. He looked again. It was definitely him.

“Wait, did you arrest Sir Kyle?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“And you cut his right arm?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“What about you?”

“Excuse me?” asked Javier.

“I mean, are you hurt?”

“No. Thankfully.”

“Okay, good. That’s all that matters,” Lloyd assured.

That was truly all that mattered to Lloyd. Once he confirmed that Javier was A-OK, Lloyd finally let out a chuckle of relief. He trudged toward Javier, standing side by side as the exhaustion started to creep up inside

him. Meanwhile, the queen got down from Lloyd's back and joined the two of them.

"Listen."

Her voice dripped with seriousness and dignity. Like a roaring lion, her voice brought silence across the banquet hall. The swords that pointed to Javier hung down, and dozens of guards gulped in nervousness.

"Tonight, Sir Kyle dared to assassinate me, and these two brave men have risked their lives to save my life," announced Queen Magentano.

Even amid the poisoning and lack of energy, she remained indomitable nonetheless. Everyone in the hall took their knees before her prideful and relentless declaration. Not a single soul dared to lift up their heads or steal a glance at her. And as her announcement shed light on the events, everyone was greatly shocked. The trustworthy Sir Kyle, the commander of the knights, turned out to be the traitor. And when they slowly lifted their heads, they saw Lloyd who was supporting the queen even now. Then, everything became clear. Lloyd Frontera. This man protected the queen tonight, they thought to themselves. Just then, a message popped in front of Lloyd.

Ding Dong.

[You have accomplished yet another stunning achievement tonight.]

[All of your past achievements and accomplishments have satisfied a hidden condition. A new system has been made available as a result.]

[<Compliment System> has been activated.]

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Chapter 101: Unexpected Spoiler (1)

[All of your past achievements and accomplishments have satisfied a hidden condition. A new system has been made available as a result.]

[<Compliment System> has been activated.]

Eh?

Lloyd's eyes went wide when he read the messages that popped out of nowhere.

Compliment system?

Lloyd had never heard of it before. Things like "likeability" or "RP" appeared so many times that he grew familiar with them. But "compliment" was unheard of. But Lloyd didn't panic because the answer to his questions was in the message itself.

A hidden condition... Hmm...

The countless achievements and accomplishments he had undertaken after he arrived in this world replayed in his head.

Career-wise, it is quite impressive for me.

The word "impressive" fell short of capturing his feats. Just off the top of his mind... He revived the flat-broke barony, formed an alliance with the orc tribe in the wilderness, killed a monster that was the size of a skyscraper, and almost became the son-in-law of a count. And tonight, he put a stop to an assassination attempt on the queen. In short, he had saved the country.

And such accomplishments accumulated until I satisfied a hidden condition.

Lloyd could guess what was happening, and he suddenly grew hopeful and expectant.

A compliment system. I wonder what it is.

The likeability and RP he had accumulated were like wings that let him soar through life, enabling him to achieve impossible things and saving him from a host of crises. So Lloyd naturally wondered how this new system would empower him, how it would bring the impossible possible. Feeling the beating of his heart, Lloyd looked down at the message, and there was a selection window.

Ding Dong.

[You have selected the “Compliment System Guide.”]

[Praise breeds willingness. The accomplishments you have achieved are turned into a title. People will praise you using the title. Each given title comes with its own bonus skill. Additionally, at midnight of every full moon, a certain amount of compliment points (CP) will be awarded.]

Bonus skill... A compliment point.

Lloyd was still lost after reading up to that point. He opened the title list.

Ding Dong.

[You have selected the list of titles you hold.]

The titles cascaded below him.

[Exemplifying Punisher]

[Builder of Dead Estates]

[Honored Warrior of the Barbaric Tribe]

[Guardian of Cremo]

[Magentano Carry]

So this is just like the titles in video games...

Lloyd recalled the many games he had enjoyed back in South Korea. The games used to give out titles whenever he successfully achieved certain missions and quests.

The titles there gave me certain powers or buffs as bonuses. This reminds me exactly of those games. Let’s first check it out.

Lloyd selected one title and put it on a test.

Ding Dong.

[You have selected <Guardian of Cremo>.]

[Guardian of Cremo]

[Title Level: Regional talk]

Carpeted the night sky, the monster’s gaze. Stood a man’s powerful will. The city’s blaze died at his yell. The monster’s heart dropped as his feet fell. Night of disaster may not quell. But the morning ray shall fall. Come. Oh, the monster of the deep sea. Come. Oh, to the dawn of protection.

[Compliment Effect: When you fight an opponent ten times or heavier than you, “Iron Stance” is invoked. The damage you deal against the opponent will double. The damage you receive from the opponent will be halved.]

[Title Region: Entire Cremona region, including the City of Cremo.]

[Active Period of Title: 120 years]

[A title’s powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region for which the compliment was given. Moreover, the time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 6]

[Current CP: 0]

“...”

Lloyd was still in the dark about where this CP was used. But something was made clear when he read the guide.

So, I now have a buff that will last 120 years as long as I am in the Cremona region.

Come to think of it, the condition for the title was enormous, and the same went for the effect. Lloyd found himself gulping.

Okay, let me look at another one.

This time, Lloyd picked the “Exemplifying Punisher,” which was his first title.

Ding Dong.

[Exemplifying Punisher]

[Title Level: Fiefdom rumor]

The hooligan is out for trouble again! He endured everyone’s mockery. In doubt and suspicion, he fought while drenched in sweat. Against the sword of the traitor, he stood with bravery. No retreat. He remained canny. At last, he punished the big snitch. The root of injustice he plucked, willful and witty. Lloyd Frontera, the hooligan, the eldest son of the barony.

[Compliment Effect: You hold great influence on those below you. Those who work for you pay more attention to your words. Cases of disobedience and insubordination will be reduced significantly.]

[Title Region: Frontera barony.]

[Active Period of Title: 7 Years.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 1]

[Current CP: 0]

This is pretty good as well.

Judging from the description, the title seemed to have come from the time when he took care of Sir Neumann, who turned his back on the barony. As such, the accomplishment was more modest than the one back in Cremo. The period and region of influence were far more limited, too.

It’s better than nothing.

This system wasn’t like the ones in the game where he could wear only one. Using several of them at once offered great help. The more the better, especially when the time period and region expanded.

The same goes for the CP that automatically gets awarded when I wear the titles.

The usage of CP was still a mystery to Lloyd. Not a single word described where it could be used in the messages.

But it will come in handy if I save them.

Lloyd wasn’t guessing. He was sure of it. Thinking such, Lloyd glanced around, and he quickly closed the system window after reading the room. It wasn’t the best atmosphere to leisurely read the messages.

I want to look over more, but let’s read them later.

An air of disorder hung in the banquet hall. But it was dead silent. The nobles and the knights were on their knees, bowing down before the queen standing beside Lloyd. And her dignified voice reached into their ears.

“Therefore... I proclaim. Tonight, every individual who has set foot in the banquet today shall be suspended from leaving until the investigation is over. Since this is an urgent measure for the safety of the monarch, I request close cooperation...”

Temporary lockdown. Everyone in the hall would be investigated until the mastermind of the assassination attempt on the queen was found. Such declaration was spoken forth by the queen.

Looks like the most appropriate measure.

The situation involved a murder attempt on the queen, and the assassin was no other than Sir Kyle. Not a single soul could be trusted. Everyone had to be put into question. The nobles were even included in this group. Though the measure may have seemed overly strict and comprehensive, it was most necessary. And her proclamation was immediately put into effect.

Clack! Clang!

New forces arrived at the hall. The number was small, a total of less than 30. But each boasted a strong and grave aura more powerful and serious than the royal guards. Lloyd noticed the insignia on their armor and presumed who they were.

The three roses. The Order of Thornbush, the unit directly working beneath the monarch.

Just then, Lloyd recalled the beginning of The Knight of Blood and Iron. The Order was a secretive force directly working under the monarch. The royal guards were like the guard dogs that were in charge of protecting the queen on a daily basis. The Order of Thornbush was the queen's hunting dog mobilized only when traitors needed to be chased down.

Whew. They look so serious.

All of them were high-level sword experts. Apathetic killing machines. That was how the novel described them. But when Lloyd saw them in real life, he realized the novel barely did justice to what they actually looked like. The men's armor clacked and clanged as they approached in his direction. At last, the queen turned to Lloyd's side.

"Lloyd Frontera," she said.

"I am at your service, Your Majesty."

"You and Sir Asrahan have saved my life tonight. So, I shall ask one more favor from you."

"Do you wish for us to help out the Order of the Thornbush?" asked Lloyd.

“Precisely. This is why I like you. You’re very good at reading the room.”

The queen smiled in contentment. Lloyd replied with a wry smile on his face.

It’s going to be a long night.

Lloyd was exempted from being a suspect because he had saved the queen. Instead, he was to join the knights to find out those involved in the treason.

“I am at your service, Your Highness.”

I can look at the compliment system later, Lloyd thought to himself, and he bowed down. It was the beginning of a busy night.

***

The morning rolled around. And Lloyd was able to walk out of the hall only after the sun rose.

“Woah.”

The bright morning sun nauseated him a bit, and he wondered if it was because he had stayed awake all night or gone through the ruckus of saving the queen.

My head hurts.

He was tired, and rightfully so. He had spent the entire night investigating even when he was already worn out.

I don’t think I’ll ever snitch as much as I did today.

The afternoon before, he had told on the royal academy. And just on the same night, he testified everything he heard and reported that to the queen and the investigator as the person behind the monarch needed to be discovered.

Whatever. I told them everything about the Lord Great Chamberlain and all that, so it’s up to the palace now.

The investigation was beyond his jurisdiction. He did his part to save the queen and prevent her from becoming a tyrant. That alone was a goal achieved.

I never want to experience this ever again.

His stomach churned as he thought about the fuss he had to go through the night. And then, he suddenly became curious.

“Hey.”

“Did you call me?” Javier asked.

Javier shot back with a question right away. A laugh escaped Lloyd.

“Look at you. All I said was ‘Hey.’ How did you know that I was calling you?”

“Just a hunch. Please do ask.”

“Ask what?”

“Do you not have something to ask me?”

“Are you by any chance... a mind reader?”

“I just had a feeling that you might have one,” said Javier coolly.

“Aha. You are a psychologist.”

“...”

“What I meant to ask you was about whether you became that,” asked Lloyd.

“Do you mean a sword master?”

“Yeah.”

“Yes, I did.”

Pfft! The sound of something spraying out came from the opposite of Javier. When Lloyd turned around, he found Julian looking at him, and then Javier with a flustered expression on his face.

“Eh...? Sir Asrahan? Sword master?”

“Yeah.”

“But how can you say that so easily?” Julian asked in wonder.

“Then, should I say it with more difficulty?” asked Lloyd.

“No, it’s not that, but…”

“Then, what do you mean?” asked Lloyd.

“You know, you and Sir Asrahan. We’re talking about him being the sword master. But you two talk so nonchalantly like you are talking about breakfast.”

“Hmm,” drawled Lloyd, “should I have asked as though we’re talking about lunch then?”

“Oh, come on. Don’t joke with me,” Julian said as he waved his hand.

“I mean, there’s no need to make a fuss, don’t you think?” asked Lloyd again as he chuckled and shrugged.

Surely, he was happy that Javier had become the sword master. But it was something that he knew would happen. It was just that he became one earlier than what was written in the novel.

“No need to make a fuss, really. To Javier, he simply met his goal for this year. Isn’t that right?”

“Yes, that’s right.” Javier nodded. “That’s why I’m relieved. I was actually getting anxious because summer was nearing its end.”

“Why, because you feared you might not meet your goal this year?”

“Yes, but today, I achieved it. I’m happy.”

“By the way, did the queen say anything about your achievement?” asked Lloyd.

“She did.”

“Bet she told you to serve her, no?” asked Lloyd again.

“Yes.”

“And what did you say?”

“I rejected her.”

Julian was drinking from his cup when he sprayed it again. Javier, unperturbed, continued to speak.

“She wanted to see me separately right after the investigation. Her voice was serious.”

“What did she say?”

“She told me that the position of the commander of the royal guards is open,” Javier explained.

“Did she promise to offer you the position? The queen?”

“Yes,” Javier nodded as he spoke. Then he added, “So I told her I don’t want it.”

“And?” Lloyd stared at Javier intently.

“She asked why.”

“What was your answer?”

“I told her that my only master is Baron Frontera, and no one else.”

Javier’s voice grew more serious as if he felt assured by his own words.

“Thankfully. Her Highness understood my heart. She smiled and said that she envied the baron. I am very relieved,” said Javier.

“Yes, truly, it’s a relief,” Lloyd couldn’t help but smile, and he thought Javier’s reaction was very much like his.

The same thing happened in the novel, I think.

In the novel, Javier turned down the offer from the queen and the emperor to work for them. And the reason he gave them was pretty much the same as what he just gave.

I think it was about how there was only one lord for him, and that was the late Baron Frontera.

With such talent, Javier could’ve lived a life of fame and luxury, but he rejected all those good things for the sake of loyalty.

Seriously, he’s an impressive guy

Lloyd internally clucked his tongue and looked at Javier. He was smiling like a student who had finished his homework in time for a vacation. But his smile vanished soon.

“I wonder, however, who was behind it.”

“The assassination attempt of the queen?” said Lloyd.

“Yes.”

Javier’s voice was cold.

“Whomever the person was, Sir Kyle was cajoled into the scheme. The sword master of the kingdom and the commander of the royal guards.”

“Yes, it’s a shocking event,” agreed Lloyd. A sigh escaped him because he couldn’t put a finger on who did it. That was the case even when he finished the novel.

The novel didn’t specify who was behind such a plot.

Incomplete hook. The assassination attempt of the queen was just that. There seemed to be some sort of organization hidden in veils, but it was never brought to light even in the end. The only thing that was mentioned in the novel was about Javier secretly bracing himself for the threat that wasn’t over.

That’s the thing with authors these days. It’s just a setup for the second novel.

It was an ending, but not technically quite so. It was just an unfinished hook to be expanded in the sequel when it received more attention from the readers. The secret organization behind the assassination attempt was exactly just that.

Tsk. Why didn’t they publish the second novel?

Unfortunately, there was only one book for the novel. It looked like the second would come out soon, but it never got published. So Lloyd didn’t know a thing about the unfinished hook. That was the conundrum at the moment.

It just doesn’t feel right.

Originally, the assassination attempt should have been executed two and a half years later. So, Lloyd meant to hint at it much later. But now, it happened much earlier than expected, causing him to wonder.

But the important thing is that we were able to stop it.

Rustle. Rustle. Before he realized it, there were already leaves falling from the trees. The sign of fall hit Lloyd’s feet each time he walked. And the stroll cleared his mind a bit.

Let’s not think too much about it.

Whatever the case was, Lloyd did prevent the assassination attempt from succeeding. So what was to come after wasn’t part of his job description. After all, his goal was to live doing nothing for the rest of his life in the fiefdom.

So it’s all good as long as there aren’t any large uproars, natural disasters, monster attacks, measles, or anything like that.

The thought brought an onrush of peace to his mind. He returned to his quarters, caught up on sleep, and lazed around. He had a late dinner and stared at the night sky. And at last, the much-awaited full moon floated in the sky, bright and shiny. Lloyd waited some more as he lay on the grass in front of his lodging. As the waiting continued, he looked over the descriptions of the titles he wasn’t able to read a while ago.

The Builder of the Dead Estate makes everyone in the fiefdom cooperate with the construction projects I hold in the fiefdom... The one about the barbaric tribe lets me use the roar unique to the orc tribes... And the Magentano Carry, hmm... it gets me the absolute trust of Queen Magentano and frees me from treason at all costs...

Each title was unique and efficient in its own way. He liked them. Meanwhile, midnight came near, and the full moon stood right in the center. Just then, the message Lloyd had waited for appeared in front of his eyes.

Ding Dong.

[The full moon is lighting up the night sky.]

[You will receive CP for the five titles you have.]

I knew it.

It was just as he expected. The corners of Lloyd’s lips rolled upward. Fixing up his posture, Lloyd read down the messages.

[The people in the Frontera barony are showering you, the Exemplifying Punisher and Builder of the Dead Estates, with compliments. You have acquired 3 CP.]

[The orcs of the Sand and Steel Tribe are showering you with compliments for being the Honored Warrior of the Barbaric Tribe. You have acquired 2 RP.]

[The entire Cremona region has turned upside down from your reputation as the Guardian of Cremo. You have acquired 6 RP.]

[The news of you being the Magentano Carry is spreading to all corners of the kingdom at the moment. You have acquired 11 RP.]

[Current CP: 22]

22?

To be honest, he didn’t know where this CP would be used. So that may have explained the uncertainty of whether the number “22” meant plenty or not. Just then...

Ding Dong.

Another message appeared right away as soon as the previous ones disappeared.

[You have succeeded in acquiring CP for the first time.]

[As a result, you can spend your CP to enable “Ending Spoiler,” which gives you a glimpse into the future.]

[Skill Name: Ending Spoiler.]

[Skill Class: ???]

[Required CP: 20 (1st)]

What...? Ending... Spoiler?

An unbelievable message appeared in front of him. Lloyd’s eyes widened as he read it.

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Chapter 102: Unexpected Spoiler (2)

What? Ending Spoiler?

Lloyd's eyes widened at the unthinkable message. He had to read the skill window twice, word by word because it was utterly unbelievable.

It's real.

The system didn't lie. Lloyd had already benefited from the likeability and RP system multiple times. He organized his thoughts with aplomb. The ending spoiler. The name itself already somewhat told Lloyd what it was about.

Okay. I'm in the novel right now. But my actions have altered many parts of the story. And this system shows me how the story has changed down the road. Just the skill I needed."

Come to think of it, it indeed was the case. The Frontera barony should have already crumbled and gone under if things happened, according to the novel. The baron couple, Lloyd, and Julian were supposed to die tragically. But none of them did, and the family remained strong. Their debt was cleared, and his estate was thriving…

It's the same for Javier.

According to the novel, he should still be wandering around and not yet become a high-level sword expert or completed the Asrahan Core Technique yet. But now...

He's a sword master. And not enough with that, he's obtained the triple circle in the Asrahan Core Technique and freely uses mana blasts whenever he wants.

His growth was sped up by a few years. At this rate, it was a question of how much stronger he would be. Who knew? He could become more

powerful than in the original story when he became a grandmaster with hexa circles.

Anyway, my stay of a year and a half has changed a lot of things. It’s my doing. It’s a good thing, but I can’t say it’s without any negatives.”

There obviously was a serious downside, and it was that the future was becoming more unpredictable.

It’s because of me whose actions constantly affect this world, ultimately changing the turn of events in this world. That’s why the story keeps differing from the novel.”

Just like so, the events would follow a course different from the original story. And it would divert more and more down the road.

Case in point. This event.

The assassination attempt of the queen. This incident should have taken place two and a half years later based on the novel, but it happened this early on. And the cause behind the treason was yet to be revealed. Lloyd racked his brain, but nothing particularly stood out. That was the problem.

This simply means that the relative upper hand I had in this world is slowly slipping out of my grasp.

Since Lloyd read the novel, he had access to the information the other didn’t. He enjoyed the exclusive, superior access to information. To the people in this world, he was almost a prophet. But once the events in this world veered off from the novel more and more...

It’ll be impossible to make predictions or anything.

His biggest weapon, which was the information, would be lost. And thinking about it troubled him.

Just when things were going for the worse, this skill came up at a perfect time, letting me look at the future.

Lloyd read the message on the skill window once again.

Ding Dong.

[Skill Name: Ending Spoiler.]

[Skill Class: ???]

[Required CP: 20 (1st)]

[You can take a peek at the portion of the ending scene that will unfold in this story by spending some of the CP. It may be a happy or sad ending.]

I knew it.

It was just as he had expected.

Okay, let’s give it a try.

The ending that was soon to come. His heart raced expectantly at the thought of looking at it.

Please. Please. I hope I’m growing old, enjoying the best of life.

A life lacking nothing. A marriage that was a match made in heaven. One son and one daughter. Two dogs and a cat. Thinking about what to eat for dinner and the summer vacation. Those would be the biggest concern in his life. Lloyd wished that such an ending would appear, where he would grow old with much ease and peace.

And if there are any, it’ll give me just a hint of the stumbling block that prevents me from living such a life.

Lloyd thought that he might find the element that prevented him from living the best of his life. If he did, it would be instantly removed, he said to himself. Lloyd rolled his eyes and selected the “Activate” button below the skill window.

Click.

[Would you like to use the Ending Spoiler?]

[Required CP: 20 (1st)]

[Current CP: 22]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it’s a yes.

Ding Dong.

[Ending Spoiler has been activated.]

[You have used 20 CP.]

[Current RP: 2]

Messages related to the skill usage appeared, and right after that...

Crackle...! Time around him stopped. The wind, flying insects, and falling leaves hung in the air.

What is this...

Just when he thought so, Lloyd saw a space about five steps ahead of him tumble. It tumbled and flashed a light until it cracked, opening a round and white passageway.

A portal?

It looked like one. He struggled to look into the bright white inside. But it waved and fluctuated as though it was motioning at him to come. It reminded him of a pond filled with freshly squeezed milk.

Would it be all right to go there?

Lloyd was doubtful for a second, but he reminded himself that the system was always right. He decided to trust it, took a step, and held out his hand.

Slosh. His fingertip produced a concentric circle on the surface, and it grew larger until it pulled his hand. Softly and gently, Lloyd walked inside, and finally, a blinding light radiated in front of him.

Fwoosh! Lloyd wondered if he blinked and opened his eyes or if a new landscape appeared in front of him. If so, what was the pool of blood on the ground he was seeing?

What is this...

Lloyd tried to open his eyes wide, but his body remained still against his will. He willed to do so, but his body forced him to furrow his brows. Moreover, against his will, Lloyd started to talk to himself.

“At that time... I should have come back as soon as possible.”

As soon as possible? I should have come back?

The voice dripped with regret. Lloyd wondered what he was saying and what situation he found himself in. His mouth moved once again.

“If so, this wouldn’t have happened.”

Another round of regret-filled voices. And his head slowly lifted, at last, allowing Lloyd a better look at his surroundings. The entire village was in ruins. The houses and woods were nibbled, and corpses lay everywhere. Crows flew around, drooling. The scene expanded to be etched in his mind so deeply that it would appear in his nightmares.

What is this... What the?

Lloyd asked himself why he was seeing this landscape in the ending spoiler. He was thinking so when the familiar ground came into his view. The path that cut across the ashen village straightened. It was a road of about 190 feet in width. The middle part was higher than the corners, and each side was closely covered with flat rocks that were about 2 feet. The corners of the road were installed with a waterway that was 1.6 feet wide and 0.6 feet in depth. And the waterways were externally wrapped with 10-feet wide

pedestrian walks on both sides. Lloyd closely studied it because it looked familiar. Soon, he learned what it was. Via Appia, the ancient Roman road. Ppodong had painstakingly dug the ground, and the civil engineers had smoothened them out. People cocked their heads in wonder, and at times, threw a gaze of wonder. Regardless, they dug, smoothened, and constructed until the job was done and brought a host of praises from people. Lloyd wondered why those people who praised him then were lying on the ground. The bar owner seemed to have died on the ground while trying to run away. The civil engineers had been engulfed. And so many more. This place was...

This is the Frontera barony? This?

Shiver. Chills ran down his spine. He couldn’t believe it. Just then...”

Whiiing.... An eerie noise blared in the distant sky. Lloyd looked up, and a dark cloud was blanketing the sky, coming fast in his direction. No, it wasn’t a cloud as water particles didn’t have eyes and wings.

“Master Lloyd, we should go. Now.”

Someone spoke in front of him. Javier’s back. Even he was soon enveloped in darkness. The sky was gone with the gray cloud, and so was the sun. The darkness engulfed his surroundings. Tens of thousands of sets of arthropod eyes came near. Their wings sounded like a storm.

“…!”

Javier shouted something for the last time, but it was buried under the noise.

Fwoosh! A ray of light smeared the sky in front of Lloyd. And he clamped his eyes shut by reflex.

“…”

Chirp. Chirp. Amid the night wind that brushed against his skin, bugs chirped and cheered peacefully. Lloyd opened his eyes as he heard those

noises. The view of the palace's backyard appeared. There were no ruined estates or lying corpses. Lloyd grabbed both of his knees.

“Whew...”

Beads of sweat streaked down his forehead, and there were goosebumps all over his skin. And he clenched his teeth as the muscles tightened in his face.

“What did I just see?”

The system did say that it was a spoiler for the ending, which granted him a sneak peek at the ending should the current course of events continue.

This is my ending if I continue moving forward this way?

The barony paid off the debt at last. Only a life of peace and cushiness awaited him. All he needed was to go back to the barony.

I can’t believe that tumbledown village is my barony.

Lloyd couldn’t believe it. What kind of joke was this? The question blurted out of him on its own. But Lloyd shook his head.

No, it can’t be a lie.

Lloyd was on the crest of a wave because of the likeability and RP system. But if he chose to turn a blind eye and avoid taking action because he saw something negative...

What I just saw can really happen.

So, Lloyd needed to take some kind of action, no matter how small that was. Even if the system lied to him, coming up with a plan didn’t harm him. Right now, he needed to prevent the ending he just saw. The first step he had to take? Analysis.

Okay. Let’s look back at what I just saw.

Lloyd breathed in and out first, trying to collect his pounding heart. His eyes slowly recovered calmness.

First, the location. It was the Frontera barony, for sure. The Via Appia in the rubbles is the proof."

But what about the time period?

Near future.

The voice in the ending scene wasn't much different from the voice right now, and it only meant that he hadn't grown old. The same went for Javier. He was young and youthful, just like now.

The clothes. Javier and I still had the same travel clothes we wore to the palace when we came here.

So, perhaps, whatever happens, it was to take place around the time they go back to the barony. Lloyd was convinced that it was so.

And now, the reason behind the disaster.

Lloyd recalled the sight of his ending spoiler. The dark clouds that carpeted the sky. Tens and thousands of arthropod eyes. The stormy wings. Lloyd saw clearly what they were. Hundreds and thousands of giant locusts that were two feet long.

Dammit. First was the financial crisis, and it's a violent crisis next?

Lloyd had busted his gut making money for the last year and a half, finally paying the debt in the barony. And now, he was forced to deal with a violent crisis even without being able to enjoy peace for a moment. Lloyd bitterly thought it was unfair. It was as though he had tightened his belt to overcome a great recession, and now, a war broke out right after.

No way I'm going to lose my dream life so easily!

The barony was the land of milk and honey that promised him a cushy life. It was his lifelong insurance, savings, and pension. Lloyd couldn't let it slip

out of his grasp so easily as he could see what was going to happen if he did. The queen would express condolence and call for him because he had nowhere to go, and eventually, he would become her loyal subject. No, her loyal summon partner. Toil for the rest of his life, much like his time in the military when he became an enslaved summon partner for the administrative officer. No. Never! Lloyd bolted up.

Come to think of it, what I said earlier bothers me the most.

He told himself there that he needed to get back to the barony sooner at that time. “At that time” may have meant now. Lloyd’s walk quickened. He gave no care that it was late at night. He rushed into the palace, and though he was stopped by the Order of Thornbush, he didn’t care. After all, he had saved the queen. He was immediately let in after he identified himself.

“I have come to discuss a matter of urgency with Her Majesty.”

Perhaps it was his voice laden with anxiousness. Lloyd was immediately led to her office.

“Come in.”

The queen shot an answer even before he could explain the matter to her. The door opened, and he saw the queen sitting on the edge of the desk piled with papers. She looked like she was going over the investigative reports on the assassination. Filled with fatigue and tiredness, she gazed at Lloyd.

“Lloyd Frontera. What brings you here at this late hour?”

Her gaze seemed to ask whether he learned anything important about the assassination attempt. Lloyd removed every trace of a smile off his face and replaced it with a grave and serious one. Right now, he needed to go back to the fiefdom. But he mustn’t force it upon her with urgency and go back so precipitously. It would only bring trouble.

So I need assistance. The best kind of support I can receive in this situation.

And the right amount of fishing was necessary to acquire the necessary assistance. Thinking such, Lloyd spoke in a nervous voice.

“Your Majesty, I, Lloyd Frontera, dare report to Her Highness that the Cremona region and its eastern borders, including the Frontera barony, will wind up in a catastrophe of fire that wreaks havoc in the land.”

“What did you say?”

Lloyd cocked his head to the side. Her brows were slightly wrinkled. The bait was thrown, and it was a success. Convinced of such, Lloyd opened his mouth.

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Chapter 103: Magentano Carry (1)

“What do you mean the eastern border will be set ablaze? Get to the point. What is it that you are saying?”

The queen stared at Lloyd, furrowing her brows. Yes, surely, it would sound bogus. But it wasn’t the time to care what she thought about. Lloyd proceeded to throw bait at the queen.

“It is true, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“True?” The queen asked back.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Then, I shall ask you one thing. The eastern region is currently peaceful from what I know. No urgent message has been received, and no war has broken out. And yet, you are here reporting to me the danger of the eastern region. What should I make of this?”

“Consider it my humble counsel to the disaster that will come down soon.”

“What? Counsel? The disaster that will come down soon?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

The queen took the bait, and the fishing hook pierced her palate. Now, it was time for Lloyd to pull it up.

“I, Lloyd Frontera, humbly report to Her Majesty that the entire east side of the Cremona region will turn into ashes within a month. The houses will be burned, innocent people will die, and the agricultural lands will be reduced to ruins.

There was silence for a second. “Such a thing will happen to the entire region of Cremona within a month?” asked the queen finally.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd hung his head down. Surely, what he just said may not be true. It may be incorrect. The Frontera barony may be the only place that gets scorched to the ground, while the other regions in the Cremona remained fine. But right now, he needed to be as dramatic as possible and make a big deal out of it to draw her attention. So, he could receive a tad of support from her. His attempt seemed to have worked.

“Hmm, impossible...”

The queen’s attitude was graver than before. She no longer tilted her head or furrowed her brows. Instead, she looked more serious than ever.

“Could it be that you suffered from a terrible nightmare? Oh, do know that I am not trying to insult you,” the queen added.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Good,” said the queen. “Then, why are you speaking such nonsense?”

“I do not think it is nonsense, Your Majesty.”

“Why not? The east of the Cremona region is peaceful today.”

“It will not be in a month,” defended Lloyd.

“Hmm... One month later. Are you by any chance worried about the sultan country over the eastern range and the wasteland?”

Sultan country? Lloyd perked his ears. The queen’s words continued.

“Yes, it is true that the sultan country had significant military activity in its western border, that is, the border facing ours. I was concerned about it as well. However, there were not any signs that indicated any danger or threat toward us,” she explained.

“Could it be that they are preparing for an ambush?”

“No, they are not.”

She was straightforward about it. She continued to speak.

“According to my spies, their military activity took place only on the borders. Meaning it was just a routine exercise. Even if it wasn’t, the transfer and preservation of massive supplies for invasion would have been picked up by the spies first. But they did not spot anything. Moreover...”

She stared at Lloyd.

“Two geographical barriers stand in between the borders of the sultan kingdom and ours. I am sure you are well aware of it, yes? The vast wasteland is rife with giant monsters, and the eastern range is too rough and rugged for the military units to pass. So, it hardly makes any sense for the sultan kingdom to attack us through the eastern terrain. If it comes from the north that directly touches the border, your words would make more sense.”

Her voice was filled with conviction. She thought to herself.

Lloyd Frontera. You are off base this time.

Lloyd hung his head down without any retort or rebuttal. But even though he was wrong about it in her mind, he looked at her in a contented manner.

He must have made a mistake out of his youthful passion.

Lloyd had shown quite a lot of wit and hidden talent. At this point in time, he was the most sought-after talent by the queen. But he was young and zealous. This time, his fledgling passion must have gotten the better of him after picking up an uncertain piece of information and forming an incorrect opinion.

Should I encourage him a little?

His blunder was the result of loyalty, youthful zeal, and passion. At a time like this, she ought to care and wrap her arms around him instead of snapping his zeal like a twig. She ought to redirect his zeal to a proper channel. That was the true accepting quality and leadership she wanted to manifest as a ruler.

“Lloyd Frontera, raise your head.”

Lloyd slowly raised his head, but his gaze was slightly strange. It was shaking. Lloyd was actually deep in thought, working his head off, trying to rack his brain. But was it because he was trying to come up with various excuses? Or to draw her attention once more? No. It was because several pieces of information she just revealed enlightened him about the cause behind the catastrophe that was too soon to arrive in the land.

Crap. That was it.

The large military scale happening in the eastern range, and the monster-littered wasteland. Once Lloyd learned those two facts, a portion of the novel came to his mind.

Monster domino. The initial capabilities’ doctrine of preservation.

That was the new military doctrine the sultan kingdom planned to showcase. When? Two and a half years later. Where? Through the north as it invades the Magentano border. But the period was shortened now, and the location changed. Not the north. It was the east.

For what reason? Why?

Lloyd wanted to know the intention behind the sultan kingdom and the reason why the time and location changed. He mulled it over, but nothing came up. He just felt the urge to inform the queen about this.

“Your Majesty, I have something else to report to you.”

“Hmm. I see that you have not yet given up on your claim.”

The queen looked at a loss, and her gaze seemed to suggest the conversation was over. But Lloyd had more to say. In fact, he was just starting.

Thinking such, he said, “The military exercise the sultan kingdom is holding right now, which Your Majesty just mentioned, shall bring blood to the Cremona region.”

“What...?”

“It is true, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“Hmm. But how can you ascertain it? How is it possible for such a thing to happen? I cannot understand,” replied the queen.

“Rightfully so, Your Highness. It’s as the military doctrine and strategy is rather new and still developing.”

“Explain.”

The queen’s facial expression turned stoic. Lloyd licked his lips in nervousness.

“It’s a sort of butterfly effect.”

“A butterfly effect?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. It refers to the phenomenon where a flap of a butterfly develops into a storm across the sea after a chain of events.”

“How innovative. And such a thing will happen between the sultan kingdom and ours?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. But this time, it will not be a storm. It will be a massive ambush of the monsters.”

“Monsters?” the queen quirked one of her brows.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Explain.”

“As you know it, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd, “countless colonies of monsters inhabit the eastern wasteland.”

“True.”

“The sultan kingdom will make use of it. It will provoke and hunt the colony of monsters near the border. It will pressure them to transfer their habitat westward.”

“Then?” The queen asked, curious.

“Even a strong and large monster can never stand against the power of the military forces, and eventually, they will transfer the habitat. That is the beginning of the monster domino.”

“Domino?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. The monsters will be moving toward the west, threatening the monsters inhabiting there already.”

“Do you mean,” the queen asked, “that just like how a domino block falls to make the next one fall, forcing out the monsters will disturb the habitats until they attack the west, where we are?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. The sultan kingdom will continue the military exercise, continually pressuring the monsters to move until it affects the Cremona region.”

It would be just like what happened at the end of the Roman empire. The Germanic race was forced to escape westward by the Hun race. And just as the national escapade wreaked havoc on Rome, this world was about to undergo a similar event.

“Hmm.”

Queen Magentano thought about it until she asked, “What do they gain by doing so?”

“Preserve their initial forces.”

Lloyd was unreserved in his answer.

“While our border is reduced to ruins because of the monster domino effect, they maintain their existing forces without combat. And they can slightly

test the water as well," said Lloyd.

"They can test the waters?"

"Yes, Your Majesty. Once we fail to stop the monsters from flooding into our borders, they will invade us at once."

"But if we block the monsters for good?"

"We simply need to send the troops back," said Lloyd.

"Hmm... I see. And we would not be able to raise issues about it since they are not technically attacking us directly."

"That is exactly the case, Your Majesty. Even if we point it out to them, they shall only express their customary regrets and turn the dagger of criticism at us for intervening with their military exercise."

"They will criticize us for intervening with their internal affairs?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"..."

Queen Magentano remained silent for a while as she chewed over Lloyd's words, it made sense. If the sultan kingdom was planning a scheme, the eastern region could be greatly harmed. Thus, she started to wonder

"By the way, where did you receive this information?"

Her gaze grew stern.

"What you just said is logically plausible. Therefore, I am curious. How did you attain the intelligence that even my spies failed to notice?"

She was curious and doubtful at the same time, even if his words were true. What Lloyd nonchalantly reported to herself were the things even the palatial spies failed to retrieve. So, she could not help but take his words with a grain of salt. The look on Lloyd's face, however, indicated

tranquility. And when he spoke, his gaze was added with an additional layer of nonchalance.

“My friends in the eastern wasteland told me,” Lloyd answered.

“By your friends in the wasteland, do you mean...”

“Yes, what you presume is right, Your Majesty.”

“The orcs. The Sand and Steel Tribe.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Of course, it was a big fat lie. He had never heard anything about this from the orc tribe. But if he straightforwardly told the queen that he knew because he read about it in a novel, the latter would consider him nuts. Therefore, Lloyd decided to come up with a believable lie.

“Your Majesty, I am sure you know. The Frontera barony and the Sand and Steel Tribe formed a blood alliance, and ever since then, constant communication has been taking place. And one of the topics was regarding the areas beyond the wasteland.”

“Hmm... The orcs came across the sultan’s strategy and informed his blood ally, you?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Where is your proof that it will be executed within a month?”

“It is my hunch, Your Highness.”

“Hunch?” she asked.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd lifted his head and looked straight into his eyes. There was conviction in them.

“Someone tried to assassinate you, and the palace fell into temporary chaos. The lords in the regions cast doubt in your authority, Your Highness.”

“Therefore... the sultan kingdom will not give up this chance?”

“That is exactly the case, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd hung his head down again.

“They are the oldest enemy of ours. Which means that they, too, must have planted spies in this palace,” Lloyd stated. “It is certainly the case that they know about the unfortunate event this time.”

“Hmm. And so, you’re asking me to trust you?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

The queen paused for a second until she continued. “But there is no evidence to support that it will happen. You are only assuming. How can I mobilize the military to respond to a mere assumption?”

“You should trust me, Your Highness,” Lloyd spoke with a slight force in his voice.

“If I do, what will you do for me?”

“I shall tell everyone that you have seen through the whole threat and took measures against it.”

“All the credit will be mine,” she said.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“But what if the incident you expected does not occur?”

“Do punish me harshly.”

“Ha!”

The queen scoffed at the ridiculousness of his answer. But her eyes didn't hold any laughter. A close calculation and review of everything he had said and the consequences of his suggestions went through her head. Meanwhile, he waited for her to speak. The baits were tossed, and they were too sweet to reject.

The queen loses nothing even if she follows my counsel.

The assassination attempt dampened the spirits across the kingdom, and this could potentially change the atmosphere for the better. Chaos and disruption would instantly be removed, and domestic and international attention would be diverted to the east. To the queen, this was a joker card.

And for me as well.

He needed to save the fiefdom. A violent crisis was right around the corner after a financial crisis. He must protect his sweet home at all costs, and to do that, Lloyd needed the queen's support. It was more effective to rush to the border with hundreds and thousands of soldiers than to dash to the barony with just him and Javier. This was the reason why Lloyd didn't rush back to the barony. Instead, he came here and boldly set up a negotiation table against the queen.

Come on. Say yes. My queen. Come on. Please!

Lloyd waited for the queen's decision, direly wishing as he bit his lips. Just then…

Ding Dong.

[Your dire wish has activated a title.]

[<Magentano Carry> is starting to have a powerful influence on Queen Magentano.]

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Chapter 104: Magentano Carry (2)

[Your dire wish has activated a title.]

[<Magentano Carry> is starting to have a powerful influence on Queen Magentano.]

What is this...

Lloyd paused for a second in front of the message that appeared before him. He wondered if this was what it felt like to spot a hopeful torch from an unexpected search party.

Ding Dong.

[Magentano Carry]

[Title Level: The unofficial history of the kingdom]

Faster than anyone else, you have arrived. The poison hungry for my heart, you have plucked. Without reservation, you have left your mark on my heart. You have gasped for air in place of my breath. Your eyes trembled in place of mine. You have even tried to sacrifice your life to save mine. At last, your back carried my body, and you protected me with an indomitable spirit. My dear brave Frontera. How can I ignore you? How can I forget you? My soul is indebted to you for as long as your breath lasts and heart beats.

[Compliment Effect: As the lifesaver of Queen Magentano, you have her absolute trust. Your opinion and advice will be positively received. Moreover, for as long as her reign continues, you will never be suspected of treason or rebellion.]

[Title Region: Magentano Kingdom]

[Active Period of Title: Queen Magentano’s reign]

“...”

The message brightly floated in his eyes, and Lloyd lifted his head a little and examined Queen Magentano’s face. She looked contemplative. Her face began to brighten just then, and her grimace was now going away. Her furrowed brows softened, and the corners of her clenched lips started to move upward, at last forming a smile. Her gaze toward him turned positive, and Lloyd wondered if her smile was wry.

“Lloyd Frontera. You are truly bold and carefree.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“Overwhelmed with gratitude...?” asked the queen. “Do you even know what I am about to say?”

“I believe that you shall grant my request,” stated Lloyd.

“Ha! You are full of yourself, aren’t you?”

“Please think of it as my effort to be considerate toward you, Your Highness.”

“How eloquent you are,” replied the queen.

“Once again, I am overwhelmed with gratitude.”

“But what if your presumption is wrong? What if I don’t grant your request?”

“Then, please harshly punish me if that time comes.”

“Tsk. You always have a response to everything, don’t you?”

Queen Magentano scoffed and, at last, gave the answer Lloyd waited for.

“All right Your wish will be granted.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“No more sweet talk.”

“...”

“I have,” the queen went on, “carefully thought about your suggestion. It is truly clever. I can feel how much you have mulled over how to wheedle me into your plan.”

Her smile turned into a sneer.

“I could tell from the simple fact that I have nothing to lose when I follow your suggestion. On the off chance that the disaster of your claim does happen in the east, my reputation and authority will soar for taking pre-emptive action. Even if your prediction is wrong, I--”

“Your Majesty loses nothing,” Lloyd finished her sentence.

“Correct. I can simply argue that it was a routine military training exercise. And that kind of news could shift the attention of the political circle in the capital from the assassination attempt.”

“Therefore,” asked Lloyd, “how much support does Your Majesty have in mind?”

“I am thinking about 500 directly under my command.”

“By that, do you mean the white cavalry, Your Highness?”

“Indeed. Do you need more?”

“Not at all, Your Majesty.”

He didn’t need more, indeed. The white cavalry, which was directly under the queen’s command, may not be the strongest force in the force, but it was an elite force nonetheless. The cavalry at his side would be more helpful than having thousands of random men. Later on, Lloyd negotiated some more with the queen, particularly about the command of the forces and the length of her support. The talk was kept brief as they couldn’t afford to waste even a single second. Once Lloyd received the promise of assistance

from the queen, he hastily returned to the barony. The first thing he did to that end was wake Javier and Julian up.

“Is it true...?” Javier asked.

“Very much so. You think I’d be making such a fuss right now if it wasn’t?” Lloyd said.

Lloyd had summarized the information he had taught the queen, and the two of them instantly grimaced despite the grogginess.

“I see. We must depart now, then, I suppose,” said Javier as he flung himself out of bed. He then began to pack his bag for the trip. Julian did the same, too.

“Hey, what are you doing?”

“Huh?” Julian asked as he paused packing.

“I said, what are you doing?” asked Lloyd again.

Julian was following Javier’s lead and packing his things, albeit clumsily. Lloyd grabbed him and asked a question, to which Julian answered matter-of-factly.

“I’m packing. Why?”

“Why are you packing?” Lloyd asked as he stared at Julian’s eyes.

“What do you mean? I’m going as well.”

“To the barony?”

“Mhm.”

Julian nodded, his voice assured and firm.

“It’s my home and my fiefdom. You said it was going to get dangerous. I’m going as well. I’ll protect the fiefdom with you guys.”

“Tsk. Don’t even try.”

Grab! Lloyd wrenched the bag out of the boy’s embrace. Julian was startled, and before he could fight back, Lloyd spoke first.

“What if you tag along, and all of us die?” “What’s going to happen afterward?”

“What...?”

“Think about it. Imagine what could happen if we went back to the barony together. What if something goes wrong, and everyone in the fiefdom perishes? Who’s going to continue the family name then?”

“...”

Julian seemed to have understood at last. Lloyd spoke to him.

“That’s why you have to stay. There has to be at least one person left in the family to carry on the family name. Don’t you think so?”

“Um, but...”

“Listen to me, Julian.”

Lloyd lowered his back a little, coming down to Julian’s eye level. He then stared at him intently.

“Our job is to do all the dirty work. And as for you... You stay put. Cheer us from behind. That’s all we need. And if I fall, that’s the time when you should come and take action. Right now, save your energy for when that time comes. Got that?”

“Brother...” Julian muttered.

“What?”

“It doesn’t suit you to be so serious.”

“Dammit.”

Lloyd ran through his curly hair behind with his hand in embarrassment. Meanwhile, Javier spoke.

“Master Lloyd, we’re ready.”

Javier truly was a sword master. He had packed the bags for two at an extreme speed that transcended human capacity. Lloyd straightened his back, looked down at Julian, and grinned.

“I’m off now.”

He carried the bag and turned, feeling relieved about how the conversation went.

Whew. Operation: One Less Baggage was a success.

Lloyd actually feared that Julian would be stubborn about tagging along. That was why he came up with a plan on how to leave him behind in the capital. And thankfully, it worked.

There’s a high chance I might not be able to take care of him once I return to the barony.

It was possible that Lloyd wouldn’t have any free time and have to put his life on the line. And so, taking Julian, who couldn’t even fend for himself, was the same as putting the boy in harm’s way. The others could be put in danger as a result as well. So right now, it was for the better that he stayed in the capital. Feeling relieved, Lloyd stepped out of the lodging, where he found the two promised magical coursers.

“Whoa.”

Lloyd whistled, impressed by what he saw. The two horses were carefully enchanted by a palatial mage. A glowing silver energy swirled around their legs with a half-transparent glimmer.

“Let’s go then.”

Lloyd hopped on the horse before stealing a glance at Julian, who followed behind Lloyd in a hurry.

“See you next time.”

Thwack! Lloyd kicked the horse’s side, and the horse began to gallop.

“...!”

It was an unbelievable speed. Julian grew distant in a second, and everything in front of Lloyd came in hazy and blurry shapes.

Is this some kind of supercar that can go from zero to sixty in three seconds?

Lloyd clenched his teeth as he grabbed the rein. With his body put closely on the horse’s back, a sense of relief flooded Lloyd for having learned how to ride a horse from Javier a little while ago. What was more, this swift horse was smart. She easily avoided and jumped over everything that stood in her way, and she was considerate of Lloyd on her back. So, the terrifyingly fast speed of the trip didn’t shake him much. Lloyd glanced to his side.

“Hey, you okay?”

“Yes, of course.”

Javier’s horse was as good as his. But he seemed to be adjusting to the speed much more smoothly than Lloyd.

“Let’s go then.”

“Yes.”

Gallop! Gallop!

Lloyd and Javier. Their two horses galloped across the main road of the capital at dawn as they left a trace of silvery glitter. Julian waved his hand

quietly as he stared at the two growing far. And then his motion stopped, and his hand slowly closed into a fist.

“...”

Julian’s face was stoic, and he unconsciously bit his lower lip.

I guess I’m not much of a help to my brother.

Lloyd had cooed him with good words. He knew where Lloyd was coming from when the latter said that he should stay here to continue the family name. But on the other hand, Julian was quick to catch the meaning Lloyd left behind.

I’m a burden.

Julian wasn’t a fool. There were certain words that didn’t need to be said out loud to be understood. He knew why Lloyd stopped him from going back to the barony with them earlier.

He’s worried about me, that’s true. But it was equally true that he thought of me as a burden.

Julian clenched his fists, but he didn’t do it out of anger.

I feel so ashamed and guilty.

Julian wondered what he had achieved all this while. Javier, who was the same age as him, was already a sword master. Even though he acknowledged that Javier was a rare genius, Julian knew that he had plenty of time to hone his skills, which could’ve been helpful to Lloyd. But he didn't.

I want to be of help to Lloyd.

To do that, he needed to be good at something. He had to find something he could do. Julian lifted his head with that thought in mind. He gazed toward the road Lloyd and Javier galloped away on and made a determination.

Just wait for a while, Lloyd. I'm going to try as well, so that I can become helpful. Wait just a little more for me.

When that day comes, he would rush back to the barony like Lloyd and Javier did. He would stand tall by their side as they overcame many obstacles in their way. Julian resolutely gritted his teeth under the late summer sky.

***

Rumble! The horses leaped and galloped, creating a storm of leaves as they sprinted. The magical power of the palace mages was stupendous. The horses barely got tired, and giving about 70% of their maximum speed allowed them to gallop all day long without a break. But that speed was already faster than the full speed of ordinary horses. So, Lloyd and Javier focused on traveling, taking as little time as they could for meals and breaks. The Asrahan Core Technique was now at the triple circle for both, so they were able to pull off such a hectic journey. They galloped on and on toward the east where the sun was rising, toward the barony that was in impending peril. They rushed, ran, and charged for five straight days until they arrived at the border of the barony.

"..."

Lloyd surveyed the familiar land as he heavily breathed. The barony was just as he remembered. The green fields adorned the Maritz land, and the paved road started from there. Three and four villages were adjoined by it, as well as the baron's manor. The paved road led up to the central plaza, coal mine, and farther east. Lloyd's gaze traveled farther than that to the mountain range of the east, and he finally gazed at the peak and the sky. It was morning. Supposedly, the sun should be brightly shining over the mountain range, but it didn't. Was it a dark cloud? No. There was something more black, darker. Something unusual. A giant dark lump was covering the sun, and it was letting out a strange noise more strident than thunder.

Bzzzzzzt! Voooooooo!

Thousands, hundreds of thousands of wings fluttered in the air, and the blaring noise amplified as they approached closer. In no time, the entire swarm of locusts, whose number was too many to count, covered the sky of the eastern mountain range.

“Master Lloyd... What you mentioned... Is that it?”

Could it be because of the unbelievably horrendous scene? Javier’s voice trembled faintly. Of course, Lloyd was the same.

“Are you shaking?”

“A little bit,” Javier confessed. “Do you have any plans?”

“Of course, I do.”

Lloyd did come here with a plan. That was all he had in mind throughout the whole journey. The 500 white cavalry knights should have been marching to get here at high speed. Lloyd and Javier just needed to buy some time until they arrived. The time had come for the two to save the fiefdom as planned.

I can have a luxurious retirement only after I protect this place!

If he failed, he would be reduced to a servant of the queen and spend every minute of his life working for her until he died. Lloyd didn’t like that possibility.

Clank! Lloyd brought out the steel shovel and turned around to face Javier. Their eyes met.

“You will follow me, yes?”

“You know my answer.”

“Then, I will explain more as we run. Let’s go! Hiya!”

Lloyd kicked the horse, and she sped down the hill, entering the Maritz land with much fierceness. And toward the people panic-stricken from the locust

plague, Lloyd shouted out the item he had in mind.

“A caldron lid! Give me the biggest one you can find!”

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Chapter 105: Captain Frontera (1)

Bzzt! Flutter! Fwoosh! The two sets of wings wrapped with a film fluttered violently. Its 2-foot body flew in the air, riding and gliding along the wind until it hit another locust flying right beside it.

Bzzt! Once the hit knocked the balance off its body, it took a nosedive to the ground, falling and hitting a random branch during its drop.

Thwack! The tree branch swerved as it harshly landed, and this locust, the 86,215th in the entire swarm, shook its body. And as soon as it recovered from the fall, it opened its upper jaw wide and took a bite of the shaking branch in front of it.

Grit! The tree branch was as thick and sturdy as the thigh of an adult, but it was nothing against the locust's powerful jaw. Its husk and body was chopped off with a single bite. However, the locust refused to let go.

Grit! Crunch! Chomp!

It bit and chomped everything in its way. Anything that could be crushed with its jaws was devoured. Just like that, it continued to fill its stomach without a break. The 86,215th locust engulfed the bottom of the branch in no time, and using the trunk of the tree as a spring, it leaped high in the air.

Leap! Bzzzzzzt! It let the wind guide its way. The scenery of the vast eastern range passed beneath its stomach. Looking at the green landscape, the 86,215th locust was reminded of the farther eastern land it had left behind.

Bzzzzzzt! The eastern range was frequently described as a wasteland by people. It was where the 86,215th locust originally lived and hatched out of an egg in the spring. After shedding several times, it passed the larva phase. It was only about one foot long at this time. But one day, the environment started to change around it.

"March!"

The blaring noise of a pipe echoed across the wasteland, and it was instantly followed by a thick cloud of sand. An army of humans appeared amidst the sand. They were holding a torch and wielding it ruthlessly. The locust's antenna got scorched, and it leaped in surprise. The entire swarm started to make way for the west, where the humans were pushing them to. The locust flew westward to survive. The travel went on for a few days, but these humans were equally tenacious. They remained hot on its heels, staying near and wielding their torch. Some of the soldiers chattered, and the locust heard what one of them was saying.

"Centurion, is this going to impact the orc tribes living on the opposite side of the wasteland?"

"Of course. You still don't know it, do you?"

"What do you mean?"

"The new strategy General Mamluk devised."

"What about it?"

"These worthless locusts will wreak havoc in the entire wasteland."

"With what? A swarm of locusts?"

"It's not that simple."

"Then..."

"A swarm of locusts is just the beginning. All the monsters inhabiting the wasteland will be disturbed because of the swarm of these bugs."

"Could it be…?"

"Yes, you are right," acknowledged the centurion as he nodded. "The locusts are voracious. But what do you think there is to eat in the wasteland?"

"Barrel Milk Cactus? Could it really be that?"

“It’s exactly that. The Barrel Milk Cactus is rich in nutrition. In fact, the entire ecosystem in the wasteland depends on them. So, imagine what would happen if the locusts living in the west fly to the areas littered with cacti?”

“They would wipe out all the cactus. The herbivore monsters that eat the cacti and the omnivore monsters alike will experience a food shortage. Am I correct?

“Yes, you’re right. And naturally, all the monsters will flee to the west one by one because that’s where the mountain range is.”

“And at the foot of the mountain lives... the Sand and Steel orc tribe, our target?”

“Now you get it,” the centurion spoke and nodded.

“According to recent sources, the orc tribe has overcome their food shortage problem. They built... a seokbinggo? It’s a pickle for us. The only thing that kept them in check was the food shortage, but with that gone, they’ll soon start to expand in number...”

“It’d pose a great threat to us.”

“You’re right, so we must trample them before they get bigger.”

“Excuse me,” the soldier asked, “but what if the locusts or the monsters travel farther into the west and beyond the range? What should we do?”

“Hmm? Do you mean toward the Magentano Kingdom?” replied the centurion.

“Yes.”

“I don’t know.”

“Excuse me?”

“That’s something the higher-ups should think about, not me. It’s not our problem.”

“Hmm... You’re right...” the soldier quickly agreed.

“We just follow the orders, and that’s it. Like this.”

Blaze! The centurion laughed out loud as he tossed the torch. The 86,215th locust jumped high in surprise. Of course, the locust didn’t comprehend the conversation taking place between the centurion and his assistant in the sultan’s kingdom. And no one in the area had a clue that their current plan resembled the Joseon Dynasty’s cleansing operation against the foreigners in the north. The locust jumped high to avoid the torch, and in all ignorance, it simply flew toward the west.

And at last, it finally found refuge. The whole land teemed with sharp and thorny plants. The Barrel Milk cacti were juicy and sweet. Even though the plant wasn’t its go-to staple, the taste wasn’t so bad. There, the 86,215th locust ate and filled up its stomach to its heart’s content. But its hunger was unquenchable. It wanted to exclusively have the juice of the cacti all to itself, except that it couldn’t. There were too many others gathered up in the area.

Flutter! The fluttering din of the other locusts boomed throughout the land, and as the locusts gathered up in an unimaginable density, the 86,215th locust underwent a change in its body. Its swarm became alarmingly compact, and they were all squished together. This environment prompted the 86,215th locust to experience the same hormonal changes the locusts on earth go through.

Bzzt! Its wings visibly lengthened in just a few days, and its rear legs shortened. The transformation was an inevitable result of the extreme compact space it was in. Its risk of being eaten alive by enemies was lessened now but competition for food increased. As such, its legs needed for escaping predators shortened while its wings necessary for long periods of travel lengthened. At the same time, its body grew double in size. It was the survival of the fittest.

Bzzt! Bzzzzzzt! In no time, its body turned yellow and two-foot in size. The 86,215th locust flew across the sky with its transformed body. It glided over the eastern mountain range along with the others. The antennae fluttered, and it stole a glance at the abundant land of prosperity. Beneath the western mountain range spanned the fiefdom resided by humans. Unlike the thick and bushy woods in the eastern range, there seemed to be no signs of menacing monsters. There was no need for a second thought. Today, that was their place.

Bzzzzzzt! The 86,215th locust let its body fall with the downward air current, and it rode the wind to make a drastic descent. The human residence came close in no time, and it speedily passed the frantic shouts of the orc miners and cut across the paved road. And it charged into the biggest building it could see.

Crash! The window got smashed, and a table was broken as it crashed into the building. Then, it greedily opened its jaw and chomped anything that could be eaten.

Crunch! The edge of the wooden table was torn in one chomp, forcing a panic-stricken shriek out of a maid.

“Arghhhhh!!”

Emily, one of the maids of Marbella Frontera, was a peace-loving girl. Her daily concerns were composed of where to take the baroness for the day or what the lunch menu would be tomorrow. At times, she found satisfaction in the way her knitting was done. She was an ordinary girl like so many others. And so, Emily almost swooned in shock when she laid her eyes on the sudden appearance of a giant locust on the morning dining table.

“Ackkk! Arghhhh!!!!!”

Emily wondered if the locust was a joke of the devil. Or could it be an evil spirit that threw the organism into this world? That was how giant, grotesque, and awful the locust was. But her fear was short-lived.

Crash! Out of nowhere, a wooden chair was wielded down without a tad of hesitation and with much force. The motion held zero mercy, and just like that, the chair hit the edge of the locust's stomach.

Crunch! The chitin skin of the giant locust cracked, and half of its stomach was busted by the chair.

Kiaaaaaah!! The 86,215th locust flailed violently as it made a sharp noise. Its leaking guts smeared on the table as it rubbed the skin of its body hard against the wood. At that moment, the creature heard the sharpest outcry it ever heard from a human.

"Emily! Help me out here! Now!"

It was the baroness. She held up the chair she had brandished and gave a hard, powerful blow. *Wham!*

This time, it was its chest. A portion of its wings and chest was crushed. The locust opened its upper jaw toward the baroness to end her, but Emily was quick enough to turn the table upside down. *Tumble!*

Humans possessed a massive amount of strength when faced with a crisis. The strength this 16-year-old girl boasted was too strong for her age. Regardless, thanks to her sudden outburst of power, the baroness was safe. And the locust lost balance and toppled to the ground, and it moved for a second until it died.

Crunch! The chair punished the bug once again, smashing its head. The liquid splattered in all directions, staining the white dress of the baroness. But she remained unmoved and unperturbed, for it was a trivial thing.

"Emily, are you all right?"

"Yes... I am fine, my lady."

"Come, take my hand and follow me."

Their peaceful breakfast time was already ruined. The baroness saw a swarm of locusts blanketing the blue sky from a distance through the

broken window. Her hands shook in fear. Grabbing her hands firmly, the baroness ran along the corridor until she met the baron coming in her direction. The baron's face turned ghastly when he saw the locust's bodily fluids smeared all over her dress.

"Marbella! Are you hurt? Is everything okay?" he demanded.

"Yes, I am fine. What about you?"

"I am fine, too," said the baron.

"But you..."

Her gaze moved to his shirt, which was stained with the bug's blood. Not only that, he was holding a sword in his hand. She assumed that he had gone through a similar experience as her.

"Let's move first. Over here."

The baron led the way, sprinting along the corridor. The sound of shattering windows inside the closed doors rang aloud while they ran. And each time, everyone flinched as they all knew what it meant.

What in the world is happening...?

The baron's face went pale as a sheet. A sudden swarm of locusts in the morning? He had never even dreamed of such a thing before. This type of disaster sweeping over the land escaped every bit of his wildest imagination.

I need to quickly gather up the guards.

The baron thought so as he went down the stairs at the end of the corridor. He then came up with various ways to respond to the swarm of bugs.

I need to put up a defense line together with Sir Bayern. Thankfully, the locusts are not as strong as the wild ants. Since my soldiers are well-trained, each can take care of about five or six in a breeze. If we form a file and fight properly without breaking it...

Clack! The baron opened the mansion door, only to be frozen in shock.

What is this...

His face was frozen, and the only thing that moved was his eyes. From left to right, they scanned and processed the situation in front of him by sending the information to his brain. He analyzed the sight and finally came to realize and make sense of the situation.

I know locusts move in swarms... But how can there be this many?

What lay straight ahead was... locusts. They were everywhere in the garden. The flowers the baroness cherished and the trees he personally tended with care were now being eaten up by these bugs. He ballparked the number in the garden, and it easily went over hundreds! And slowly, they turned toward his side in unison.

Bam! The baron slammed the door shut, breaking out in a cold sweat. The shivers felt like an electric shock in his body. His breathing grew raspy.

W-what do I do?

The plan to gather up the soldiers and Sir Bayern evaporated in thin air the moment he laid his eyes on the locusts that took over the garden. When their gazes met him, every plan and operation he had formed prior crumbled to pieces.

This... This is hopeless...

Everything went blank in his head. Nothing popped into his head. The only response he could manage was bolting the door shut. That was all he could think of.

“Dear? How’s the outside situation?”

Marbella asked, and the baron wondered if he should be thankful that she wasn’t allowed a peek at what was happening outside. Should he put on a nonchalant face and suggest hiding in his place? The baron found himself of two minds.

Thwack! Thwack!

The bolted doors jerked like someone was banging it with a large hammer or a voracious beast was chewing the door.

“Arghhhhh!!”

Emily, who was looking around beside them, shrieked aloud, drawing the baron couple to finally see the doors being penetrated by ten upper jaws of the locusts. And when they clamped shut, their teeth bored holes larger than human fists.

“Woah...”

The baron was terrified when he realized what was happening.

The locusts are chomping down the door.

No, to be technically correct, it was the whole house that was being gnawed by the locusts!

“Eek! You bastards!”

The baron wielded his sword at the locusts trying to make their way into the house by eating up the doors. Their bodily fluids splashed in all directions, but two more jumped at the exact spot one locust died. Two died, only for three to jump and eat the doors. The holes started to widen, but the baron’s frantic sword saw no stop. The baroness joined in by grabbing a flower vase. Emily held up a candlestick, crying. At last, the doors finally broke down completely.

Crush! The doors were already breaking as more than 20 locusts latched onto them. As the doors grew smaller in size, the weight of the bugs was too much to bear. And soon enough, the doors crumbled down.

Crash! Snap! As the doors snapped in half, the swarm of locusts entered freely, their eyes glimmering in hunger at the humans.

“Piss off, you pests! Ackk!!”

The baron brandished his sword, but it was pointless. There were just too many bugs. One man’s sword stood no chance against the waves of bugs.

“Move back! Now!”

They retreated, rushing back to the way they came. They went up the stairs, but they could not run beyond the entrance of the second floor.

Crash! Tumble! The doors that lined up the corridor crumbled, broke, and snapped. Locusts flooded out of the broken doors into the corridor. And just like that, the baron couple and Emily were trapped on the stairs by the swarm of menacing pests.

“No... No...”

The baron bit his lip. The baroness held up the vase, and Emily clutched the candlestick in tears. He direly wanted to protect them, but nothing sharp came to his mind. Doom. That was the only thought that overwhelmed him.

“Honey...”

He held out his free hand and tightly held her soft hand. The locusts came closer from both sides. They were drawing near. The baron wondered if he should be thankful that his last moments were with his loving wife. The baron couple shut their eyes amid the despairing romance. The locusts spread their upper jaws toward them. Their rear legs crouched to pounce at the human meal. Just then...

Bong...! Bong...! All of a sudden, the entire place was gripped with a clear, reverberating noise. It sounded like a bell. Or a large cauldron lid. The noise reverberated throughout the land with much intensity. The swarm of locusts stopped dead in their tracks at the noise. At last, the baron couple heard a strangely familiar voice.

“You pests! What do you say? The sound of the cauldron lid is getting you all so excited, right? Isn’t it demanding your attention?!”

Bong! A clear, ringing noise started to come closer. At the same time, a welcoming voice rang even louder in their ears.

“Over here! If you’re enticed, come get me! I am Captain Frontera, you bastards!”

Bong! The majestic sound of the vibration echoed throughout the land, and the baron couple murmured the owner of the voice by reflex.

“Lloyd...?”

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Chapter 106: Captain Frontera (2)

Bong! A low, clear reverberation spread across the land, sending a wave of vibration in the air. When it touched the locusts' bodies, it stimulated their auditory organs connected to their chest and rear legs and ultimately tapped their nerve center. When that happened, their nerve center reacted, prompting them to go after the reverberation.

Bzzzzzzt! The 132,645th locust that was about to pounce at the baron paused and loosened the strength in the rear legs. It fixed its posture for attacking and whipped around toward the source of the noise, which was coming from outside.

Jump! The 132,645th locust leaped through the broken window to make its way outside. The others followed suit. Like some invisible, giant power was manipulating them, every locust wheeled around as soon as the first one jumped out the window. They all stampeded to go out before the others, smashing every bit of the remaining windows and denting the windowsills. Each stomped on the other to rush out ahead. And just then, the reverberation stimulated their ears once again. *Bong!*

What's happening...?

Baron Frontera widened his eyes as the swarm of locusts thundered out of the manor in a flash. He couldn't believe what was happening.

"Arcos, did you hear that?"

The baron turned to his wife at the question.

"I did. There was a voice along with the bonging sound of a bell..."

"Lloyd," Marbella Frontera stated.

The baron and the baroness nodded as they looked at each other. They were sure about it. It was definitely Lloyd, whose voice the two could recognize even in the deepest parts of Hades. The two hurried right after, rushing

down the stairs and going past the destroyed entrance. And they sprinted across the empty garden to finally arrive at the main gate that granted them a wider view of the fiefdom. They saw thousands and tens of thousands flying in one direction, pursuing two coursers and their riders ahead of them.

“Lloyd...? Sir Asrahan...?”

The baron and the baroness murmured in fright. Just then, a locust flew past right in front of them to join the rest of its crew. It flew beyond the manor approach and fell on the roof of the only bar in the village. The bar owner shrieked in surprise, but the locust didn’t care and simply leaped high again, finally joining the tens of thousands of its species. This event happened in several parts of the fiefdom.

Bong! The echoing sound came again. A locust eating up some hay in a stable paused and spat it out and rushed toward the sound.

Bong! The low, clear noise came for the second time. The locust about to attack the calf stopped. It then flew outside, giving up the juicy-looking cow meat.

Bong! The reverberation came one more time. The young shepherd crying in fear, the hunter girl protecting her friend, the civil engineer holding his family’s hands and praying, and the young mother protecting her newborn baby all saw the locusts freezing right before pouncing at them. They saw the pests giving up and opening their wings wide to follow the sound. And later, at last, they saw an unimaginable spectacle unfolding in their fiefdom.

Bong! Javier brandished his sword with the cover on, and it hit the cauldron lid, creating a loud banging noise. The dark lid, which was almost 4 feet in diameter, echoed heavily, and Lloyd yelled aloud behind the lid.

“Good! Let’s try it one time!”

Lloyd was on the fast-galloping courser, holding the lid like a shield. Javier was right beside him and gave a full swing of his sword once more when he heard his young master.

Swish! Booong!

Javier hit while Lloyd defended. The sword knocked, and the lid protected. Each time Javier knocked the lid with his sword, he produced a low and clear reverberation around him and attracted a larger swarm of locusts. But they weren't being encircled by the throng of bugs, thanks to the magic spell that made the horses very fast.

"All right! Hahaha! Herding is what makes hunting trash mobs so fun!"

"What's a trash mob?!" Javier shouted.

"Don't worry about it! One more time!"

"Yes, Young Master!"

Sprint! Booong!

They produced a reverberating noise in front of the swarm, and the size of the locust swarm continued to blow up as it chased after them. A soft smile spread across Lloyd's face.

Great. Everything is going according to plan.

The plague of locusts swarmed around him, and his operation was working very well. Lloyd called to mind the story in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.*

The description was about the orc tribe in the eastern wasteland.

In the novel, orcs lived off hunting monsters, but the hunting didn't always end up with a bang. There were multiple instances when they went hungry. And orcs had a plethora of methods they used for survival when the stored food emptied out. One of them was producing a low, clear echo using a gong in the middle of the wasteland.

I think it was this kind of echo that attracted the swarm of locusts inhabiting the wasteland. The novel described that the wavelength produced by the bonging sound is similar to the sound they make to call their partners during mating season.

Lloyd decided to trust his memory and give it a try. That way, he thought, it could bring the locusts into one place.

I should gather them all in one place and kill them in a single strike. If not, I'd have to whack all of those bugs dead one by one. Not a single blade of grass would remain in the barony before I get the chance to do that anyway.

Any other method would lead everything in the fiefdom to be eaten up. The grass, the house, and the people. Everything. It would be a wretched end for Lloyd as well. So, he wanted to avoid this sad fate as much as possible. Before such a fate became his, he had to efficiently kill all the locust swarms, and he could do so only by gathering them up in one place.

That's what herding the trash mob is all about. Like this!

Slash! Javier swung down his sword sheath, and Lloyd protected the blow with the lid.

Bong!

Ouch...

Javier must have struck down with too much power. Lloyd's hand and arm went numb as the powerful vibration and shock traveled through his whole body. It felt as though he was on a New Year's bell that people rang to announce the first day of the year. Or it felt as though he was tightly hugging a concert mega woofer speaker like a pillow. His stomach churned a little bit.

"Hey?" Lloyd called.

Lloyd peeked through the edge of the lid, and he stared at Javier with a straight face.

"I'm starting to notice that your emotions are leaking into your strikes."

"Excuse me? I'm not sure what you mean."

Javier, who was lying flat in line with the horse's head, glanced at Lloyd's side and quirked his head in confusion.

"I am simply and dutifully doing what you tasked me to do."

"Ah, is that so?"

"Yes, like this."

Fwish! Booong!

Ouch!!

His stomach churned once more, and Lloyd narrowed his eyes to slits.

"I think your swing has gotten stronger."

"Well, that's because the harder I hit, the louder the echo will be and the more locusts will swarm."

"Is that so? How about we switch? You hold the lid," suggested Lloyd.

"Why?"

"I think I can strike harder with the triple mana blast."

"I refuse."

"Why?"

"I like the way it is now."

Fwish! Booong!

Another blow. It was stronger this time. Lloyd's face crumpled as much as the blow, but it was equally effective. The locusts began to pursue them with more tenacity.

Okay, the operation is working successfully.

In all honesty, Lloyd had been uncertain about the plan, but it was turning out smoothly. He felt like he had become Peter Piper.

“Okay. Now! One more time!”

Lloyd happily held the lid and defended Javier’s blow. Who hits who didn’t matter right now. Lloyd was ready to get hit hundreds and thousands of times.

As long as the fiefdom is safe, this is nothing!

And if this assured him a happy life of retirement, he was ready to take all of it. Resolving such, Lloyd quickly surveyed his surroundings.

Great. The rounding-up is taking place very nicely. Now, I need to minimize as much damage as I can.

Rounding up the locusts was essential to the plan’s success, and it was going very well. Now, it was time to expand the range. He had to round up as many locusts as possible. That was how he would be able to take care of the locusts in one stroke.

“All right! Let’s run one lap like this! Around the outside perimeter of the fiefdom!”

“Yes, Young Master.”

The two guided the horses to the outskirts of the fiefdom, galloping along the main road. They removed themselves from the central village and passed the villages, paddies, fields, and fruit gardens. And the bonging noise from the lid continued to echo aloud. Everywhere the two went, they attracted a new set of locusts. From 50,000 locusts, the number reached 200,000 now. But it kept growing and growing. Lloyd, however, wasn’t satisfied with it.

“To the south!”

Right after Lloyd succeeded in rounding up the trash mobs after a lap around the fiefdom outskirts, he proceeded to point to the south where the

Maritz land stood. No, he was actually pointing the land beyond the Maritz land.

“We’re moving up to the viscounty. Make sure to follow me!”

“Yes, Young Master.”

A soft glimmer appeared in Javier’s eyes. Lacona Viscounty? It was a bit of a surprise.

Is he trying to help out there as well?

The viscounty was on bad terms with the barony. No, it wasn’t just bad. The two were practically enemies. But come to think of it, Javier thought the residents there were innocent people.

Master Lloyd must have first thought about the safety of the residents and put behind his inconsequential resentment against Viscount Lacona.

Javier nodded. It was obviously the case. If the barony was under attack by the locusts, the same fate would await the Lacona viscounty as it sits right beside the barony. People there would be suffering from the plague that appeared out of the blue. Javier never thought that far. He looked back at Lloyd, his gaze mixed with admiration.

Just then, a new message appeared in front of Lloyd.

Ding Dong.

[Javier Asrahan is touched by your righteous action.]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by three points.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: +8]

[You have earned 54 RP by improving your relationship with the main character.]

[Current RP: 4083]

Huh. Righteous action?

Lloyd couldn’t help but smile in a wry way. Javier must have misread his gesture.

I’m not going there for righteous reasons.

Sure, he was going there to help. But not because he felt pitiful or sorry for the people there. It wasn’t due to an overwhelming sense of righteous indignation either. There was only one reason behind his move to the viscounty: to protect his cash cow.

The water bill! I can only receive it if the viscounty is safe!

If the viscounty went under, his efforts to install the waterway would go down the drain. He had decades' worth of water bills to collect from the viscount, and that would be gone if the cash cow died. Such an unfortunate event had to be prevented at all costs. And from the perspective of clearing the locust swarm, his decision was obvious.

If I leave the locusts in the viscounty, my barony will receive collateral damage anyway.

They could target the barony after annihilating the viscounty. So, to exterminate them to the hilt, he had to clear both those in the barony and viscounty.

“So let’s go now! Faster now! Hah!”

Lloyd prompted the horse and tightened the muscle in his hand that grabbed the lid. The magic in the horse became more powerful.

Clip clop! Clip clop!

They approached the outskirts of the viscounty. They were right. The same hell had broken loose in the viscounty. The entire land was swathed with giant locusts. People’s panicked screams and the locusts’ wings produced a symphony of chaos throughout the area.

“Let’s go! Hah!”

Lloyd kicked the side of the horse. He and Javier charged without hesitation. They jumped over the main road, passed the village, and cut across the entire viscounty. Javier and Lloyd continued to produce the bonging noise. The guards fighting till they bled, the farmers and wives on the run, the crying boys and girls, and the babies smiling at the locust trying to eat her... Everyone heard the reverberating sound at the critical moment. They were saved by the echo Lloyd and Javier created.

Bzzzz...! Hundreds of thousands of locusts covering the viscounty flew high in the air, and they left behind their prey and began chasing Lloyd and Javier. Rounding up these pests in this area was a success as well.

“All right! Now we return to the barony!”

They rushed forward with a track of 500,000 locusts behind them. This procession was all devised and premeditated.

The Maritz Wetland. The river embankment. We just need to get there.

Lloyd thought about the stand-by point where he placed Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang. The place Lloyd had designated. The Extermination Zone. That was where he would exterminate every locust, booking them a ticket to discuss their afterlife with Hades.

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Chapter 107: Captain Frontera (3)

Crackle!

“…!”

Suddenly, there came a violent rustling noise ahead. Lloyd ducked down.

Scratch! A leg of the locust brushed his nape. It burned. He wondered if his skin was torn by the claw. But Lloyd didn’t have the mind to give thought to such an inconsequential matter. There were hundreds and thousands of swarms of locusts coming into his view straight ahead.

“Dammit.”

Lloyd thought he was doing a good job at rounding up these bugs. He had carefully designed the route to make sure that most of them would follow from behind, not the front.

I knew the range was just too wide. They’re practically all over the barony and viscounty.

And so, some of the locusts still managed to fly at them from the front, even with the well-planned route. The problem here was that “some” meant hundreds and thousands.

“Master Lloyd, please brace yourself.”

A plague of locusts swarmed from the sky toward them, their flapping wings sounding like thunder. Javier’s solid voice was heard amid such. A corner of Lloyd’s lips lifted upward.

“Oh... Come on. I’m not ready yet.”

He was far from ready. After all, he was no hero. He was no courageous warrior in a storybook. As such, hundreds and thousands of giant locusts hurtling toward him with such hostility was not something he enjoyed.

I feel like I’m going to lose it!

Bugs were repulsive. He always hated bugs, but his hatred worsened when he lived in a small dorm room. The thing was that his dorm wasn’t those trendy, modern studio-type rooms. It was dilapidated, old, and rotten. Cockroaches and centipedes appeared so often that they sickened him. After a while, the sight of anything with more than six legs disturbed him. And now...

I have to run into hundreds and thousands of locusts that are the size of a dog. This is nuts. It really is!

For a split second, Lloyd considered calling it quits and leaving the fiefdom. Just turn back and head to the capital and beg the queen to give any work to him. But he soon realized that he didn’t have any time for reveries. It was already too late to run away. The locusts were nearing ahead, and Lloyd was galloping right into them!

“Oh, damn it! The problem is me!”

Whatever happened, happened. Lloyd brought the caldron lid in front of him.

Thwack! Clack! Twang! A series of hits banged against the lid, but they weren’t any ordinary blows.

Argh!

Blows, incomparably more forceful than Javier’s hits, came in dozens. There was no surprise here. Lloyd was on the enchanted courser, and she was easily traveling over 60 miles per hour. Moreover, a hefty locust weighing several pounds was flying from the opposite direction and rushing toward him with immense speed.

Compute the impact of the caldron received by each blow... My ass! Save me!

Thud! Twang! His arms slowly went numb, and shoulders trembled. He felt like his back was about to snap and legs were about to fold. If it weren't for the triple circles that fueled him, he would have already toppled to the bottom.

And if I fall, thousands of locusts will fight to take a bite of me!

Shiver.

With that thought in mind, Lloyd barely held on with a struggle. Javier, too, was of great help.

"Turn your head this way! Run parallel to me, so you can follow the route even without your vision! And hold your lid slantwise! You cannot take the full impact! You must let it flow off!"

The fluttering of their wings sounded like hundreds of electric fans whizzing all at once. When Lloyd heard Javier, he obeyed immediately, tilting the lid diagonally. This slightly lessened the blow sent to the lid, and Lloyd was able to somewhat breathe.

How's Javier holding up?

Lloyd was now curious how Javier was enduring when he didn't have the lid. His voice seemed all right. And when Lloyd turned around, he saw...

Ziiing! Slash! Fwoosh!

Running right beside Lloyd, Javier and his horse were enveloped with a brilliant ray of aura.

How can a human wield a sword like that?

Swoosh! Slash! The sword igniting with aura danced, slashing, and slicing through the space. Everything in its way was slashed. Everything that rushed at it was cut to pieces.

It looks like he's swinging ten electric fly swatters at once.

Lloyd was impressed. Javier brandished his sword at a transcending speed, creating a storm of aura as he hit directly against the locust swarm. He was chopping away every single one of them, and whenever he saw a chance, he even used the mana blast at Lloyd's side.

Wham! Boom!

Each time he blasted the mana, he shot three or four shots together. His moves weren't random. The angle and route of his blasts were carefully calculated, and the distance was closely adjusted, intersected, and overlapped. The blasts had a narrow and long path to follow. Javier shot, making sure that the range was widened with maximum effectiveness.

Thwack! It was a regular blast, but it was as powerful as Lloyd's triple mana blasts. It appeared that Javier's was more efficient when it came to strength consumption.

I don't know, should I call this a 2+1 mana blast? As I thought, what a monster.

Even so, the locusts kept rushing at them from the front. Lloyd ducked a little lower, and he encouraged his courser.

"Hold up just a little more! You can do it!"

Neigh!

Lloyd was grateful for his horse, who was faithfully galloping even when she was going out of breath. Had it not been for the magic spell on the animal, he wouldn't have been able to even attempt this kind of plan.

"Let's go!"

She moved as if she became one with Lloyd.

Clip clop! The horse wasn't galloping ahead like a fool. Sometimes, she accelerated and turned just in time. A slight twist to the left to push to the right. She avoided, fought, and leaped above the incoming bugs. She even took into consideration the wind, noise, and other threats. Lloyd reacted as

well, reading every movement around him, and he began to get the hang of it.

“Like this!”

Thud! Lloyd brandished the lid hard, knocking the incoming locust charging from above. It bounced to collide with another and plunged to the ground. The horse trampled and instantly killed it with her hooves. Just like that, Lloyd penetrated the throng of bugs ahead of him. Of course, the swarm of locusts continued to pursue him from behind. He estimated the number to be hundreds of thousands. Javier’s aura or mana blast or even his triple mana blast wouldn’t do. Chills ran down his spine when he thought so.

“Keep running! Hah!”

Lloyd galloped in full vigor. They were now out of the viscounty territory, and they made for the north. Familiar paths and terrains came into his view. The land that was once a wetland. The land that was now reclaimed by the collective efforts of everyone. The Maritz Wetlands.

“Over the hill and to the waterway embankment!”

That was where the Extermination Zone Lloyd made was. They had to hold on just until they arrived there. Just then...

Neigh...

“Huh?”

The courser, who was galloping just fine until now, started to slow down. Surprised, Lloyd examined the animal.

“Hey?”

Neigh! Neigh! Huff!

There was foam around the horse’s mouth. She, however, seemed to be trying hard not to give up.

She’s tired.

Even the best horse had her limit. Magic didn’t come without limits.

Well, it makes sense. She’s been galloping since dawn. And she never took a single break while getting to the fiefdom.

And right after she arrived at the barony, she had to run full-speed to round the pests up. She lapped around the outskirts of the barony once before running to and around the viscounty. And during those times, she never slowed down. She ran like someone running a marathon at the speed an athlete runs for a 100-yard dash.

Did I overwork her so much that not even magic can help her anymore? What should I do?

Lloyd glanced beside him to check if Javier’s horse was all right. The same thing was happening there. Her speed had visibly slowed down. And her legs weren’t stretching far anymore. She would definitely collapse if he pushed her more.

We should get off before that happens.

Right now, they were being chased by hundreds and thousands of locusts. The horses would collapse and fall if Lloyd stubbornly pushed them to move ahead by a few yards. The unprepared fall might even lead to serious injuries on Lloyd and Javier’s parts.

It’d be a total loss for everyone. That’s not good.

Javier must have read Lloyd’s thoughts. Or it could be that he noticed the fatigue in the horse. Javier sent a similar meaningful gaze to Lloyd. Their eyes met, and their exchange was done.

We get off here.

Yes.

Twup! There was no reason to hesitate. Lloyd placed his hand on the horse saddle, jumped with his two feet, and flung his body high.

“Make sure you are safe out there! Don’t let your guard down because you’re somewhat safe. Make sure you go far!” Lloyd shouted.

Slap!

“Neigh!”

Lloyd slapped the buttock of the horse to thank her for her service. Suddenly feeling light all of a sudden, she charged forward after giving a neigh. She disappeared in a flash. By the time Lloyd landed, she was already 21 yards away from him.

“...”

Goodness... That horsey looks so alive and well the moment I get off. Lloyd instantly removed his doubt because he had to run now. Plus, he was getting near the Extermination Zone in the Maritz Wetland.

“By the way, what are you doing?” Lloyd asked as he turned to the side.

Javier held up his sword, and his eyes glimmered with resolution.

“Master Lloyd, go first. I will protect the route here.”

Swish! An aura appeared as soon as he finished his resolution. It started to spiral around his sword. This was the brilliance only sword masters who reached the mastery of sword fighting could muster. The brilliant sword of the knight protected his lord, reputation, and vow. Javier turned his back against Lloyd, showing his back brimming with determination. With bravery, he confronted the menacing procession of locusts. Lloyd’s heart started to race. And he wielded his hand just as his heart pounded. Then, he slapped the back of Javier’s head.

“Have you lost your mind? Are you planning to fight those things right now?” Lloyd gaped.

“Master Lloyd? Why did you just…”

“Protect the route, my foot! Are you saying I should run away and leave you here to die? Come, carry me now!”

“Carry you, Master Lloyd?”

“Now! We don’t have time!”

The distance between them and the locusts was now 100 feet. Lloyd loudly yelled, pushing Javier, and without waiting for an answer, he jumped and got on Javier’s back.

“Run!”

“...”

Javier grimaced for a moment. But he instantly understood the meaning of his young master.

I see. He made a practical decision.

Jump! Javier turned around and started to run, charging straight ahead with Lloyd on his back. Now, Lloyd started to bang the lid with his fist.

Bong! The reverberation stimulated the locusts once more, pushing them to pursue him harder. Now, the distance between the two grew closer. 80 feet.

“Master Lloyd, did you hint at me to get off after you calculated the whole thing?” Javier asked as he maintained the speed.

“What do you mean ‘calculated’?” asked Lloyd.

“Getting on my back,” Javier said.

“Of course.”

Lloyd scoffed behind Javier’s back.

“I don’t run fast. I may be faster than ordinary people, but I am not confident I can outrun the locusts. But you are different. You are fast.”

“But with you on my back, I cannot ascertain that I will succeed. You could have easily run away if I stopped them in the front,” Javier reasoned.

“I’m doing this because I don’t want that.”

“...”

“Come on. Do you have some fantasy to become a hero in your head? Why do you keep trying to die so often? You did this back in Cremo as well.”

“...”

“Let’s just stretch the idea, and you leave behind so awesomely and die. And I live because of your sacrifice. You think that would make me feel good? Huh?”

“Master Lloyd...”

“I don’t want that. So run faster. Come on! Giddy up!”

Slap!

“Please don’t treat me like a horse.”

“I’m just paying you back,” Lloyd said.

“Paying me back? What do you mean.?”

“The ant cave. After the explosion. Our escape. Does it ring a bell?”

“...”

“I got you on my back and walked out. Remember what you were like?”

“I can’t remember.”

“Aha. Really? That’s too bad. I remember it all,” Lloyd said.

“...”

“Anyway, let’s leave this place together alive. It won’t be right if one stays and dies while the other runs away and lives. It’s also just unfair.”

“...”

Lloyd Frontera. Javier wondered how much truth was in his words. Sometimes, no, most of the time, the young master puzzled him. But he knew one thing for sure. He wanted to get out of this place alive together.

“I like the sound of that.”

Leap! He leaped higher. The distance between them and the locust was 65 feet. But Javier didn’t look back. He knew he should spend his energy and time to sprint harder instead. Every fiber of being focused on staying alert and not losing balance. He activated an endless circulation of manaheart. And he transferred the amplification of the triple circle to this circulation.

Fwoosh! Javier forced his tired leg to use every last strength it had. He imbibed his tenacious resolution in his raspy breath. Javier ran against the wind and crossed the hills. The locusts were now just 32 feet away. The flapping of their wings sounded terrifying in Javier’s ears. And straight ahead, just about 100 feet away, was the Extermination Zone.

“Fiver more steps!”

A shout was heard from his back, prompting him to take five more steps. His fifth step was taken with the son of the lord on his back. He took his fourth to actualize Lloyd’s words and make it out alive together. His third step was to push himself until the end. His second to maintain his focus. Last...

“Jump to the side!”

Leap! Javier reacted instantly, and he jumped and flung his body to the side, falling flat on the waterway. Now what, Javier wondered. Just then, he felt

Lloyd grabbing the back of his head.

“Get down!”

Lloyd’s hand pressed down Javier’s head, and he obeyed and ducked down. There was a distance of 15 feet between them and the locusts. And then, Javier saw...

“Bangul!”

Jingle! Jingle! He saw the fat, rattling tail of Bangul as she emerged from the woods with a jingling noise. He saw the storm of explosion coming out of her.

Boooom The volcanic blast, whose power Javier had never seen before, burned and engulfed the incoming locust swarm.

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Chapter 108: Saved by the Bell (1)

Slump! A locust reaching up to two feet tall fell to the ground, all burned and sooted like a lump of charcoal. The bug obviously didn't move. It was already dead, so there was no resistance. It remained immobile and frozen even when a farmer, who was yawning in fatigue, leisurely raked its body.

Yawn.

Crunch! Crash!

One raking motion caught three or four locusts at once. Every single one was burnt like coal, and they swept into a mountainous pile.

"Whew. This is a lot."

Sir Bayern, the senior knight of the barony, encouraging the clean-up, shuddered. They were creepily large in number, which he had felt the previous night when the pests swarmed into the place.

Still, it's a relief that almost no one got hurt.

Sir Bayern recalled the previous morning. It was a normal morning. He had woken up like any other day, washed his face, and hurried to his morning training. It was right after he stepped outside his house that he heard the scary, booming noise from the eastern sky.

I had never seen anything like it before.

A plague of locusts had swarmed and blackened the sky, covering the sun and clouds. The whole surrounding was dim as if it was nighttime. The mere thought of it brought chills to his spine.

It felt like the end of the world.

He was flustered. No, he was scared. A part of him wished to leave everything behind, head back to the house, hide in the deepest corner of the

attic, and stay there. But he was the senior knight of the Frontera barony. Though he was way behind Javier in terms of sword fighting, the responsibility to command the civil engineer corp and guards fell on his shoulders. The sense of responsibility felt more real in a disaster like yesterday's. He rushed to the barony manor instead of locking himself up in the house. He meant to assemble the engineers and guards and fight back. But it turned out to be difficult.

I was surrounded by the locust swarm before I could even run 200 yards.

Dozens of locusts came at him, and still, he brandished his sword amid the chaos. It was the worst battle he had experienced. He started to grow tired. The sword felt heavy in his hands, and his legs slowed. The end seemed near for him. What a meaningless death, he had thought to himself. Incapable of protecting anybody. Failed responsibilities. Death in the throng of bugs. Just then, an unexpected reverberation started to drum in his ears.

It was Master Lloyd.

Sir Bayern lifted his head and gazed toward the embankment. A man supervising the clean-up efforts stood there. It was the eldest son of his lord, Lloyd Frontera.

I'd have died if it weren't for him.

He was certain about that. If the echo didn't interfere with the bugs just then, he would have perished for sure. If Master Lloyd didn't knock the lid and lure the locusts away, his body would have been ripped apart alive.

It wasn't just me.

Countless people throughout the fiefdom went through the same thing. The wetland migrants piling the locust carcasses, the civil engineers fatigued from the clean-up, and their families would have kicked the bucket if it weren't for Master Lloyd. Sir Bayern was sure about that. At that moment...

"I think we can call it a day."

A voice was abruptly heard beside him. Sir Bayern flinched at the noise, so he turned to the side.

“Why? Do you wish to work more?”

“...”

Lloyd, who was on the embankment, was walking over to him before he knew it. The young master must have come while he was in a daze. Thinking such, he cleared his throat.

“Master Lloyd, if you wish to, I shall extend the clean-up.”

“You want to do more? But the sun is setting,” Lloyd insisted.

“I am at your disposal,” Sir Bayern stated.

“Yeah? Okay. Let’s work through the night until the sun rises tomorrow morning. And while we’re at it, let’s take it up a notch and finish it quickly.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

Sir Bayern nodded, and he immediately turned to call the soldiers in higher ranks. But he couldn’t do so because Lloyd cut in first before he could call them.

“Woah there. Are you for real? Are you serious about the overnight job?” Javier asked in disbelief.

“Yes,” Sir Bayern replied.

“Wait, because I said so?”

“Yes.”

“No, no. You can’t let them work overnight so easily.”

“Then does that mean you are canceling the overnight job?”

“Of course.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

“...”

Woah. Lloyd chuckled because he couldn’t believe how faithful and headstrong the knight was.

Yes, Sir Bayern was this type of man.

In the novel, there were only two knights that didn’t betray the barony even though it was on the brink of collapse. The first was Javier, and the other knight was Sir Bayern, who didn’t appear very much in the story because he was only a secondary character.

Faithfulness and loyalty. These two words were all that described him.

Those two sides of him were more than enough. His loyalty ensured that he stood by his lord, the baron. And his faithfulness pushed him to strive till he achieved the mission entrusted to him. To capitalize on such fortes, Lloyd tasked him with the job of supervising and overseeing the ondol project early on. And he had been faithfully completing the construction projects without anything amiss.

But if I could point out one shortcoming, it’d be that he’s too serious.

Balanced resistance and snobbery. Those were the qualities Javier possessed that amused Lloyd whenever he teased the latter. But Sir Bayern didn’t have them. Feeling the wistfulness in his heart, Lloyd cleared his throat and spoke.

“You did a good job today. It’s not like we can clean that up in a day or two. There are just too many. Since the sun is setting soon, let’s call it a day.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

Sir Bayern signaled the high-ranking soldiers, and the rest of the men cheered and organized the tools. Everyone was exhausted after spending the

entire day cleaning up the burned locusts. But they didn’t leave for their homes right away. Before they hurried back to the barracks, they came to Lloyd’s side and stood in one line. And they shouted...

“We thank you, Master Lloyd!”

“Haha...? What are you all doing?”

This situation, where a bunch of grown men were coming together to thank him, flustered Lloyd a bit. But when he looked at their eyes, he was able to feel the sincerity in them.

“Are you thanking me because I saved you yesterday?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes!” They shouted in unison again.

“Woah. Forget it. I just fought hard for my retirement!”

“...”

“So, if you want to give thanks to me, then go ahead. But next time, you might want to give me a bag full of gold coins instead of shouting your gratitude. Got it?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes!”

He felt a bit embarrassed in front of their sincerity. That was why he had blurted out a nasty response, and even so, the soldiers shouted yes and went away.

Did I go overboard last night?

As Lloyd walked alone from the Maritz Wetlands to his manor, he couldn’t help but chuckle. The more he recalled what he had done in this part of the land, the louder his chuckle became. Just then, one moment of great urgency came to his mind. The final moment when he was luring the locusts to the Extermination Zone.

***

“Jump to the side!”

Bzzzzt!

The violent din of wings fluttering right behind terrified Lloyd, causing him to break out in a cold sweat. He shouted to jump to the side, and Javier immediately reacted. Carried on his back, Lloyd was flung to the side into the waterway. Lloyd then stretched his hand immediately and pressed Javier’s head down, and covered them with the lid.

Bzzzzt!

The eerie sound of the flapping wings hovered over them. There were too many for them to count. So many that their noises mixed and jumbled altogether. Like TV crackling in gray screen, they roared, except that the volume was that of 100 concert speakers blaring aloud. Lloyd’s heart pounded in a frenzy. *Now’s the time, Bangul!* Lloyd shouted internally. Just then, Bangul responded.

“Bangul!”

Boooom! A thundering noise boomed across the sky. The explosion fired at the locusts.

Kaboom! The volcanic explosion skill was activated, and it was followed by a terrible shockwave. A heatwave reaching over 1,500 °F was discharged, and bits of magna stormed straight ahead at 250 miles per hour. It rampaged and swept everything that existed within the range. The radiation scorched everything that was within a couple hundreds of feet. Only two people could remain safe in that distance.

“Duck down! Lower!” Lloyd shouted.

They further lowered their body to the waterway of the field. And the lid on them protected most of the heat charging down from the sky. And the rest was absorbed and discharged through the Asrahan Core Technique. They were able to survive one volcanic storm like this. Then, Lloyd rose up.

“Now! Hit it!”

Thud! The two sprang to their feet. Lloyd held up the lid while Javier lifted his sword.

Booong! The sword hit the lid, spreading the low, clear echo across the site. And the walls and hot air surrounding them amplified the echo to spread faster, stimulating the locusts who froze at the sudden explosion. It allured them and drew them near.

Bzzzt! The locusts started to move again like hungry predators.

“Good! Let’s try it one more time!”

Booong! Another bong reverberated in the air, and hundreds and thousands of pairs of wings flew near them in greed. At that moment, Lloyd and Javier lowered their bodies deep into the waterway. Then, another explosion boomed near them.

“Bangul!”

Boooom! Trillions of tiny glass shards as hot as 1,500 °F swept the entire sky at the speed of 250 miles per hour. The awful radiation and fierce shockwave blasted everything within dozens of yards. The second explosion brought more than 10,000 locusts to be scorched to death. Bangul prepared for the third shot.

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

She widened her big mouth, and Ppodong fiercely dug up the soil to throw them into Bangul’s mouth right away. Once it was eaten and digested, a reload was complete for the third explosion.

“Ready!”

Booong! The reverberation, frenzied locusts, and loud signal.

“Now!“

Boooom! Fire, eat soil, hit the lid, attract, and fire. The rampage cycle was ruthless, devised for complete extermination. On top of that, Hamang joined in and threw a trap.

“Hamang, now!”

“Hamang!”

Gulp! Gulp! Splash! Hamang, who was standing by, jumped into the river across the embankment and started gulping the water, taking in as much as he could. He then lifted his head and sprayed the water high in the sky as far as he could manage. More than 25,000 gallons of water flooded the sky like a torrential pour, attacking the locusts that were about to run away from the continuous explosions. Once the water soaked their wings and dropped them to the ground, Lloyd jumped up, and Javier drew his sword. A second later, the ground shook from the west.

“Here! Do not forget our spears and knives!”

Clip clop! Gallop! 500 cavalry knights armored in white appeared in their view. The white cavalry the queen had promised finally arrived. They charged like a tsunami, stretching out the lance in shiny white. They swept the locusts lying on the ground, penetrated them with their lances, and pierced far into the rear file of the locust swarm. And later, Lloyd and Javier’s shovel and sword glinted.

Kaboom!

Lloyd’s triple mana blast. Javier’s series of delicate mana blasts. The destructive mana storm swept the locust swarm. The fear quickly spread among the bugs like a disease. They expanded their wings wide and flew high to escape. And once again, Bangul fired another shot of the volcanic explosion to welcome those that flew in the air.

“Bangul!”

Boooom! Volcanic ash adorned the fiefdom sky like a mushroom cloud.

***

It was such a spectacular day.

His past day had been filled with tense and suspenseful moments. If a pest control company employee was there to witness the events, they would have sent a tearful standing ovation for their extermination method.

It's a relief that it worked.

Everyone was able to live because Lloyd's operation and bold execution worked perfectly like magic. The fiefdom was saved from the crisis as well. With that, Lloyd jostled himself out of his own reverie as he walked. Around the time the sunset disappeared on the horizon, he arrived at the barony. The manor was in a hot mess because it had been chewed and bitten all over the place. It looked like a pair of ripped jeans that had been badly torn by a grouchy fashion designer.

"It is a relief that the building didn't collapse. If the young master arrived any time later, this manor would have crumbled to ruins."

A clear voice spoke when Lloyd was staring at the house at length. Lloyd found that a maid was standing at the main gate. He ballparked her age. 15 or 16. The freckles on her face made her stand out. Lloyd remembered that she mainly served the baroness.

"Emily?" Lloyd said as he remembered her name.

"Yes, Young Master. The baroness sent me to escort you to the dining room once you arrive."

"Sure, yes."

Lloyd wasn't sure why she was so happy. He wondered if she was pleased to escort him. Emily's face was filled with a smile, so Lloyd found her a bit uncomfortable to be around.

I can never get used to this kind of treatment.

He had never been welcomed like this back in South Korea, particularly after his parents passed away. But this world was different. Everyone called him “Young master” wherever he went. They sent gazes of reverence and gratitude, saying that Lloyd saved them and the fiefdom. Everyone was the same as this smiling and cheerful girl who turned around to steal a glance at Lloyd at times as she walked ahead of him.

“Actually, young master,” Emily said.

“Huh?” Lloyd replied.

“I started to knit something today,” confessed Emily.

“Knit? What knitting?”

“You know, cross-stitching.”

“Oh, okay.”

“I plan to stitch something awesome.”

“Ah, is that so?” Lloyd spoke in an indifferent manner.

“Yes. Something really awesome. The most awesome thing I’ve ever seen.”

“Um, I wonder how awesome it is.”

“The sight of you risking your life for everyone,” she finally said, blushing.

“Woah...”

Lloyd almost burst into an endless cough. But Emily seemed clueless to it as she merely continued to speak in a feeble and soft manner.

“To be honest, I was very scared,” she confessed.

“Yeah, you were?”

“Yes. I thought I was going to die. Right here, at the top of the stairs.”

“Here?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes. I was surrounded by the locusts.”

“You must have wanted to faint,” Lloyd added.

“That was when you showed up,” Emily said, almost choking in admiration.

“Hey... I’m hungry. Let’s move faster.”

Lloyd felt like he was about to die of embarrassment. He quickened his steps to walk ahead of Emily and enter the dining room first.

But before he could do so, Emily interrupted, “So, young master....”

Her voice was a grip that clutched at his sleeves. And she bowed right away before he had the chance to say anything.

“Thank you.”

“...”

“You saved me. Thank you. You saved my younger brother, grandma, and everyone else. You’re our lifesaver, young master.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes. I hope you enjoy your dinner.”

“Yes, thank you.”

Lloyd was at a loss in front of such heartfelt, sincere gratitude. Emily ran away, all blushing and red after she was done speaking. Lloyd put on a wry smile as he looked at her back. Just then...

Ding Dong.

[You have shown an act of heroic courage and determination by risking your life for the Frontera barony and Lacona viscounty.]

[For that, the people of the two fiefdoms are touched and praise you very much.]

[You have earned a new title.]

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Chapter 109: Saved by the Bell (2)

[You have shown heroic courage and determination by risking your life for the Frontera barony and Lacona viscounty.]

[For that, the people of the two fiefdoms are touched and praise you very much.]

[You have earned a new title.]

“...”

Hmm... Finally, Lloyd thought to himself. When the message appeared in front of him, he perused the message without a show of surprise.

I suppose I saw this coming.

He had gotten quite used to receiving messages in moments like these, so he expected this to happen from the second he started to exterminate the locusts.

This was the perfect time for a new title.

He had risked his life and saved the fiefdom. Therefore, it would be only upsetting if a new title didn’t come out. In fact, it was the reason why he had paraded around hollering that he was Captain Frontera and saving everyone.

Otherwise, no one is going to know who came to save them. Why bother accomplishing anything if no one is going to acknowledge me?

The importance of PR could not be emphasized enough in an age like this. Thinking such, Lloyd studied the message that continued to pop up.

Ding Dong.

[A new title <Bell Saver> has been created.]

[Bell Saver]

[Title Level: Regional talk]

Murky clouds covered the eastern sky. Carrying an apocalypse, they flew. Livestock perished, houses crushed. Humans weeped, swords snapped. When death neared everyone. When two fiefdoms despaired as one. A bell tolled aloud in unison. *Bong*. The livestock was saved. *Bong*. The people woke up. *Bong*. Hope was alive. That's why we shall chant out for our savior.

[Compliment Effect: The Frontera barony and Lacona viscounty, who have undergone the attack of the plague of locusts, will consider you as their lifesaver throughout your lifetime. Moreover, every form of insect monster instinctively will fear you and get discouraged when they see you.]

[Title Region: Frontera barony and Lacona viscounty.]

[Active Period of Title: 110 Years.]

[A title's powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region where the compliment was given. Moreover, the time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 3]

[Current CP: 2]

Woah.

Bell Saver. Its effect was as grand as the name sounded.

Does this mean that I became the most respected hero in the region?

That wasn't all.

To summarize its effects, I can automatically discourage insect monsters.

Come to think of it, this optional skill was awesome. The description didn’t even mention any limits on things like the size of the monster.

This means that there are no conditions attached to it whether it’s the size or whatever else. Anything that’s shaped similarly to an insect will be affected by it. So, this means that something like the Gigatitan that I had fought back in Cremo would be scared and shy away from me if we met eyes.

If he was in the modern world, pest companies would have paid big bucks to hire him. Nonetheless, its effect was going to come in handy in many ways in this world as well.

I’ve had a lot of unlucky experiences with insect monsters.

He really did. The wild ants, the Gigatitan, and the locust swarm... Each and every single monster was yet another great crisis to overcome. But if he had held the title back when he was fighting them, victory would have come easily. He wouldn’t have had to risk his life so many times.

And I think it’d be very useful for catching mosquitoes in the middle of the night.

That might be the sweetest take away from the title. Lloyd closed the message window as he grinned contently. He looked across his table, where the baron and baroness were enjoying dinner. The two appeared to be happy, basking in the peaceful dinner. Understandably so. The fiefdom had faced an unprecedented disaster, and it was overcome by their heroic son. How could they not be happy? How could they not be satisfied? Lloyd could easily understand the baron and the baroness. But it didn’t mean that preparation for other possible future attacks wasn’t necessary. And so...

“Um, I am sorry to say this to you right now, but it won’t end with this,” announced Lloyd.

Lloyd spoke with an empty salad plate in front of him. The happy conversation between the baron and baroness ceased right away. They

gazed at Lloyd, which was followed by the concerned voice of the baroness.

“My. Do you wish to eat more salad?” she asked innocently.

“...”

“You should have told me. This isn’t the end? Well, I suppose I should’ve known that wouldn’t be enough for them. Still, you must be tired from traveling all the way from the capital.”

The baroness spoke and then took Lloyd’s plate to serve him a full heap of salad. Lloyd looked at it. There was way more meat than vegetables on his plate.

“Tell me if you need more,” she added. “Today must have been tough for you, too.”

“Um, I didn’t mean that way, but-”

“Care for some sausages?”

“...”

His heart was touched against his will. Memories were problematic for this very reason. Lloyd wondered why mothers were like this. He shoved away the thought of his mother that flashed across his mind, and he forced a cough to remove the awkward expression from his face.

“Ehem. Hmm! It’s not that, but I actually do have something to tell you both,” Lloyd finally managed to say.

“What is it?” the baron asked, and the baroness put down the salad spoon. The two seemed to have noticed that Lloyd wasn’t talking about food. Lloyd gazed at them.

“Please forgive me for what I am about to say while you are feeling happy and relieved,” Lloyd said, “and it makes me feel like a wet blanket to say

this. However, there will be time to celebrate later on. The same goes for you both and me."

"Is..." the baron murmured, "something going to happen again?"

"Yes."

"Will it happen again in the future?"

"Yes."

"Can you tell us in more detail?" the baron asked once again.

"Of course."

The baron's gaze was now serious. Feeling the intensity, Lloyd opened his mouth to speak.

"Yesterday's disaster was terrifying, to say the least. Thankfully, we managed to overcome it well. But now is just the beginning. To tell you the reason and our current situation in detail..."

Lloyd began to walk through the whole thing one by one, just like the time he had reported the matter to Queen Magentano. The things he had learned from the novel and the facts he managed to deduce were laid on the table in a logical manner.

"Therefore, a string of invasions, just like the one we'd witnessed, will occur down the road."

"A string of them?" asked the baron.

"Yes, it's..." Lloyd paused for a second before he spoke again. "I am expecting three to seven at most."

"..."

The baroness blanched at Lloyd's words. The happy-go-lucky and peaceful atmosphere that hung on the dining table was instantly killed to be replaced

by a horrendous and suspenseful one.

“Ha... What should we... How about we leave the fiefdom at once?” the baron suggested.

“That won’t do.”

Lloyd shook his head firmly before continuing. “You must remember, that once we lose the fiefdom, it’s over for us.”

“It’s over for us?” repeated the baron.

“Yes.”

It was true. Abandoning this fiefdom wasn’t an option. This fiefdom held his dreams, hopes, and a comfortable and prosperous retirement life for Lloyd. And if they gave this place up because of the monster hoards and let it become ruined, it would become a wasteland. All of the villagers would either die or flee. And what would happen afterward?

We’ll lose the fiefdom. Some might say that we could simply run away for safety and establish the fiefdom again on an empty lot. But this isn’t a video game. Doing that would be impossible.

If the fiefdom’s lord and his family fled for their lives in front of a threat... That would nuke the people’s trust in the lord. Even though he poured gold coins into building up the agricultural lands and distributed them to them afterward, they wouldn’t be so willing to settle there. No, even before that happened, the royal palace would surely come to grill the baron.

Since a fiefdom is nothing but a land given by the monarch.

Therefore, it was to be managed and maintained on behalf of the monarch. Abandoning the land was the same as stripping himself of the qualification to rule over the land. The land would forever be out of his rule.

“And so, running away must be the final resort when death is our only alternative. First, for now, we must stick around here and protect this land.”

Lloyd never wished to lose the fiefdom. He didn't wish to wound up homeless and be summoned to the capital. The queen would then comfort him and give him a job there, where he would be committed to a lifetime of backbreaking work. He had been snowed under endless work and labor already enough back in South Korea as he tried to make ends meet. It sickened him. His strong resolution seemed to have been conveyed well to the baron and the baroness. The former nodded with a resolved expression on his face.

"I understand what you mean. You are 100% right," the baron acknowledged.

"Isn't that right?" Lloyd said, feeling relieved.

The baron, who seemed to be afraid, mustered up the courage. Lloyd thought that since he and the baron were on the same page, things would be much easier to plan out. However, it was revealed a second later that the baron must have mustered up too much courage.

"So, you shall run away alone," the baron announced.

"Excuse me...?" asked Lloyd, dazed.

"As you said, countless monsters and beasts will sweep over the fiefdom as the locusts did. That is why."

"I don't get-"

"If you need to survey and design things for defense, just do that and nothing more. As soon as possible," the baron explained.

"Wait," Lloyd asked as he grimaced a little, "are you saying I should run after assigning the project to someone else?"

"Yes."

The baron's tone seemed to tell Lloyd, "Duh."

“What would be the point of putting yourself at risk? You have risked your life already by taking the matter into your own hands this time. I am sorry and ashamed of that alone. Therefore, from now on, you shall stay somewhere safe. Don’t act recklessly from now on. Let this old man deal with it.”

The baron’s voice was stern, which was something rare for him. And so, Lloyd was able to catch how serious the baron was about keeping Lloyd safe, even if it meant putting himself in danger.

“...”

Lloyd was touched once again. He wondered why his father came to mind. His father used to comfort Lloyd that everything was okay and that he must focus on his studies as the old man could pay off the debt. The baron reminded Lloyd of his father, who spoke with conviction like now.

When in fact, he was the one most scared and tired by it all.

Why fathers always tried to carry every single burden all to themselves was beyond Lloyd. He drew his breath at length, smothering emotions that tried to spill out of him. And he spoke to the baron.

“But even so, it will not be enough,” Lloyd said.

“Not enough...?”

“Yes.”

“Are you saying that your father will not be able to protect the fiefdom?”

“No. That is not what I mean. However-”

“However?”

“Things will be much easier if we work together. So, here is my promise,” Lloyd said.

“Promise? What promise?”

“Without looking back, I will run as soon as things get dangerous. To a faraway place that is safe. How does that sound?”

“Are you really serious about keeping that promise…?”

“Of course,” Lloyd assured.

That was obviously the case. Even though this barony was his golden ticket to a happy retirement, it wasn’t more valuable than his life. The moment he sensed he was near death, he would be the first to run. Thinking that in his head, Lloyd spoke to the baron.

“So you do not have to tell me to run away first. Instead, I wish to ask you for something.”

“Ask for something? What is it?”

“Please provide me with as many workers as you can.”

“Is it to shorten the time needed to build a defensive structure?” the baron asked.

“Yes. We need more workers on top of the villagers and civil engineers. Especially those who are strong and brawny. So...”

Lloyd paused as he stared at the baron. With a grin on his face, he uttered a request that was sure to frighten the baron.

“Please summon the commander of the White Cavalry after dinner for me and tell him that the entire member of the cavalry will be transferred to the civil engineer corp first thing tomorrow,” Lloyd said.

“What...?”

Gulp-

It was only seconds ago that the baron promised full cooperation to protect this fiefdom.

I know that we have been given the command control as the lord of the fiefdom, but it's directly under the command of the monarch! What is he going to do with them?

The baron was concerned that the commander of the cavalry might go apoplectic. But Lloyd was nonchalant, and he spoke much more brazenly.

"Of course, you should be worried. And about how you will bring it up to him is another concern. I wish to do it myself, but I am not the lord. So, the job is yours, and it's imperative that you do so," said Lloyd.

"Imperative? Why so?"

"Because it's our chance to attain 500 brawny and well-built laborers."

Lloyd continued to speak.

"The next wave of monsters will rush down here now that the locusts are gone. We will need people for shoveling then," he added.

"Shoveling?" the baron asked in curiosity.

"Yes, but not just this time. I have a bigger, much bigger picture in mind for the future. So they must master how to use the shovel and get used to the tool beforehand. Please make sure that you make them come around. Also, if he gets mad..." Lloyd paused.

"What if he does?"

Baron Frontera shot the question in a hurry, thinking that Lloyd might have a wonderful trick up his sleeve. He waited for the hopeful answer to come. Lloyd grinned.

"Act thick-skinned and brazen," Lloyd finally uttered.

"..."

"You can do it."

“…”

“Good luck.”

“…”

The baron wondered if he could really pull off such a thing. His Adam's apple fluctuated hard as he gulped.

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Chapter 110: The Meaning of Shoveling (1)

It was late at night, around the time when almost everyone got ready for bed. Some might already be asleep, enjoying sweet dreams. But it was an exception for one. The commander of White Cavalry, Sir Valeradi Blanc, was the exception. He was trudging ahead as he breathed heavily in annoyance.

What a rude situation this is...

Clank! Clank!

He recalled what happened a while ago, and that prompted his steps to be more violent. For a good reason, however. He had gone to meet Baron Frontera in his office as per the request of the latter. There, he heard the most preposterous offer he had never even imagined to hear.

What? He wants what? He wants to deploy the entire knights into the civil engineer corp?

It wounded his pride. Could it be any more absurd? The mere thought of it flushed his face in anger.

They expect us to hold a shovel instead of a sword and scoop soil? Us?

No way. He knew who he and his men were. They were the White Cavalry.

We are the queen's sword and lance. Our greatest honor is fighting and dying on the battlefield. Yet, they expect us to wield a shovel?

Of course, Sir Blanc resisted. He grabbed the baron's collar, and lashed out at him for daring to give such an impertinent order. Sure, the queen had commanded the cavalry to be here, which gave the power of command to Baron Frontera for the time being. But...

But still, this is nonsense!

Sir Blanc blew a gasket, bawling at the top of his lungs. And what came out of the baron's mouth stupefied him all the more.

What? It wasn't his decision?

So, Sir Blanc probed some more. At last, the baron told him that the answer was waiting at the training hall in the manor.

Fine. I'll go there. I will go because it's all so ridiculous!

Sir Blanc was sure that he would find out what this was all about once he got there.

Clank! Clank!

He tramped outside the mansion toward the training hall behind the manor. But the moon over his head shone brightly, inconsiderate to his burning rage. When he arrived there, he noticed a silhouette of a man standing all alone at the center of the training hall. The man had his hands behind his back. He was looking up at the moon, his posture straight.

"Who are you over there?" Sir Blanc asked. "Did you wait for me here?"

The man turned around. He wasn't carrying any weapons. But he had a nonchalant smile on his face, which strangely signaled more danger than a weapon to Sir Blanc.

"Yes, I've been waiting for you. You are here earlier than I expected."

"Lloyd Frontera?" Sir Blanc asked in disbelief.

"Sir Blanc, the man of great reputation, knows my name. What an honor," Lloyd answered.

"Honored my foot. I am Valeradi Blanc. I briefly saw you yesterday, but finally, we have the chance to introduce ourselves properly."

"I am sorry. I was engrossed in cleaning up the mess after the disaster," Lloyd said.

“You are not the only one who was busy.”

Sir Blanc had spent the previous day slammed with work. He inspected his people, the armor, and the weapons. As he cocked his head to the side, Sir Blanc stared at Lloyd.

“But you see, I just heard something a bit strange,” Sir Blanc said.

“From the baron?”

“So you know,” he said”

“Of course I do,” Lloyd replied. “I was the one who asked the baron to tell you that.”

“Wait, the decision to deploy the White Cavalry into the fiefdom’s civil engineer corp came out of your head?”

“Yes, indeed.”

“...”

The nonchalant manners of Lloyd almost propelled Sir Blanc to jump and grab him by the collar. However, he suppressed such desire with great struggle and spoke.

“Why? The baron told me that I would be enlightened once I came here. So don’t beat around the bush, and tell me straight.”

“To stay alive.”

“What...?”

Sir Blanc paused for a second. He wondered where this Lloyd Frontera was getting at. Lloyd continued to speak.

“I don’t want to die, but I can’t give up the fiefdom,” Lloyd explained, “On top of that, I can’t just run away all the more, leaving the people here

behind. So, I thought I should do anything I can. Resort to every means possible, and push through for as long as possible."

"So what, that was your method to prepare for the future monster invasion? Deploying my knights to be engineers of yours?"

"Yes, indeed."

"You are making a mistake," warned Sir Blanc.

"How so?"

"It would be more destructive and effective for 500 of our knights to wield the lances on battlefields than carrying shovels and joining your engineering group," Sir Blanc reasoned.

"Yes, that is right, indeed."

"What is that now...?"

Sir Blanc was curious about what the deal was with this man. Why was he consenting to his words so easily? Lloyd grinned nonetheless, which made Sir Blanc wonder if this man understood his words"

"Lances in battlefields. Yes, yes, you must let them shine bright. I am not stopping you. You have my encouragement and support. But all I am asking from you is to hold up the shovel until the monsters strike," Lloyd reasoned.

"So you want my knights to join the construction in peacetime and fight as lancers on battlefields?"

"Yes."

Lloyd's answer was curt and straight to the point, which made Sir Blanc pause for a minute. This left him speechless, and he struggled to rebut Lloyd's request.

I mean, it makes sense circumstantially.

After all, they could only act as lances on the battlefield. And here was Lloyd requesting them to grab a shovel only until those battles began. As Sir Blanc mulled it over, the suggestion appeared extremely practical.

It's not like our reputation will be damaged by holding a shovel when nothing is happening.

They only had to bring out their best game during war times. Sir Blanc thought further and realized that Lloyd's request wasn't problematic in a procedural sense as well. After all, the moment the queen had ordered them to be dispatched to this fiefdom, the ultimate control over them temporarily shifted to Baron Frontera.

But still... It doesn't feel right.

Sure, it was practical and followed all the proper procedures. However, his pride. That was the problem. His pride was hurt. The brilliant shining lancers of the queen carrying soiled shovels? Sir Blanc couldn't help but feel repulsed by that image alone. Therefore, this issue had nothing to do with profit or logic. It had everything to do with his feelings and emotions.

If even I am feeling this way, I wonder what my men will feel about it.

The 500 men in the White Cavalry. Each and every one of them was ready to throw their life away for the queen. As such, this type of order was sure to bring about some serious resistance from them. Sir Blanc, after some thinking, raised his head as he wanted to confirm something.

"Let me ask you one thing," he said.

"Sure, go ahead," said Lloyd.

"Let's say that we join your engineering team. What exactly will be our job?"

"Things the civil engineer corp does," Lloyd stated nonchalantly.

"You mean..."

“Mainly shoveling. At first, the work will be slow because you are not adept at it. But once you get the hang of it, you will surely get better than my people. I have high hopes for you,” Lloyd added.

“What...”

“I mean it. Truly.”

Lloyd was telling the truth. He wasn’t asking this type of favor to hurt their pride.

I mean, they are the White Cavalry.

They worked directly under the queen, so their combat power and stamina were verified already. Once they got the hang of shoveling, each one would do the job of three or four skilled civil engineers. What was more, they could be instantly transformed to combat capabilities once things went south at the construction scene. Lloyd had a bigger plan in mind, which was a surefire trick to put the endless brake on the monsters. To do that, they had to be excellent shovelers.

“I promise you,” Lloyd said, “your daily wage won’t be insignificant. Five times what the civil engineers receive. I am being very generous right now.”

“This isn’t about the money.”

“It is important. Many people in the whole world break their backs all day to earn money.”

“...”

“And just so you know, shoveling in a construction site isn’t as much of a waste of time as you imagine. It can be a great source of training,” Lloyd added”

“Training? Do you mean like stamina training?”

“Yes, indeed.”

“Ha.”

Sir Blanc sneered, and he wondered if this man named Lloyd was in his right mind.

I thought he was the hero of Cremo and a great talent Her Majesty acknowledged.

On top of those, Lloyd was the very person that stopped the assassination attempt of Sir Kyle. When Sir Blanc heard about the news, fright and admiration overwhelmed his soul to the point that he yearned to meet Lloyd. Sir Blanc wanted to feel the grave aura of the man behind such a tremendous accomplishment. As such, he was thoroughly disappointed tonight.

“Lloyd Frontera, it appears you know nothing about us, the White Cavalry. Do you consider us weaklings who need to train in construction sites?” Sir Blanc’s voice contained disdain”

“Hmm, don’t you think so?”

“Bullcrap. You are ignoring us.”

“That surely is not.”

“Are you saying you are not looking down on us?” Sir Blanc retorted.

“No, I am not.”

“Are you saying that construction sites can train our stamina?”

“Of course it can,” Lloyd emphasized”

“How in the world...”

Sir Blanc furrowed his brows. The work only involved a shovel. Or a hammer. How hard can it get to transfer soils and bricks? On the contrary, what kind of training did the White Cavalry go through?

We have trained every day, risking our lives. Blood and sweat amid the piercing spears and our skills were built upon the wounds and injuries. We battled in wars and drank bottles of victory, cheering for today for being alive and for tomorrow for being braver. And here comes this man to tell me what? A construction site can train us? Bullcrap.

Sir Blanc made his resolve. With a stinging gaze, he looked at Lloyd.

“How can it train us? What difference will it make if we train in that construction site of yours?” Sir Blanc retorted”

“Different in many ways.”

“Can you prove it in specifics?”

“Sure, I can.”

“Can you prove it right now?” Sir Blanc demanded.

“If you want, let me show you right now.”

“Please do so.”

“Great. But why don’t you make a bet with me?” Lloyd said.

“A bet?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd smiled meaningfully.

“From now on, I will show you the result of training on the construction site. If you judge that what you see is more powerful than your sword fighting, please make your men join the civil engineering corp without a complaint. How does that sound?”

“Ha, fine.”

Sir Blanc didn’t even think twice before saying it. *He’s going to show the result of training done with a shovel? And he’s comparing it to my sword fighting?* Sir Blanc almost snorted at the absurdity of it.

Does he not know that I am about to become a sword master?

Sir Blanc could do everything except conjure an aura. So whatever this man Lloyd Frontera was about to do, it would fall short of his own sword skills. It would be the case even if he had fought and killed the Gigatitan to become a hero. A shovel was nothing but a tool. It would not be enough. Sir Blanc was filled with conviction as he spoke.

“I will take you on that bet.”

“That sounds great.” Lloyd nodded his head without hesitation, and he picked up the shovel from the ground.

A shovel? What’s he going to do with a thing like that? It’s not even a weapon”

Sir Blanc felt how laughable this whole thing was. Lloyd could go and do whatever he desires, be it shoveling or anything. Once he saw enough, he would sneer at Lloyd as much as he could. And he would gripe about the impertinence and disrespect Lloyd has resorted to up until this point. Thinking so, Sir Blanc took two steps back lest his shirt gets soiled. But right after he did, he heard something he never expected to hear.

“Two steps won’t be enough. Step further back.”

“How far should I move...?”

“As far as you can.”

“...”

Sir Blanc took two more steps back. Lloyd shook his head. Feeling uncomfortable, Sir Blanc took five more steps back. Lloyd positioned himself just then.

“You see, the thing about shoveling is...”

Clench! His two hands tightly gripped the shovel handle. As the veins in his hands popped out, Lloyd spoke.

“It’s not as easy and effortless as you think it is.”

Zing! Lloyd started to activate three circles, tightening his grip all the more.

“Just to shovel, you should wake up early in the morning. You need to put on clothes even when the sun isn’t up, and you must leave your house with safe shoes on. And you must pray hard that you’ll be picked by the employment agency. If you don’t get picked, you can’t shovel even if you want to,” Lloyd narrated.

“...”

Sir Blanc wished to ask what Lloyd was talking about. But Lloyd continued to speak.

“The same goes for days when it pours hard. It’s more so during the stormy season, like in the summer. And in the winter as well, when you can’t just use a shovel. But even on days with nice weather, sometimes you get no job because you bought the hatred of the supervisor. Or when you’re out of luck, the job itself cancels right in the middle of the whole thing. And so, when things like that happen, you can’t shovel even if you want to.”

“What are you saying...”

“Only after overcoming such tribulations and ordeals can you finally hold up your shovel for the day. And that’s only when you have earned the right to be paid. Sure...” Lloyd paused for a second. He looked straight into Sir Blanc’s eyes. “Others may consider it invaluable and trivial. But to those who shovel, it may be their last lifeline. The very job you like to make fun of can cover medicine and school tuition. It can be someone’s final source of hope.”

“...”

“So, for some, this shoveling is a symbol of hope and life. It’s what sustains their dreams, feeds their children, and keeps them moving forward without quitting. So...”

Zing! The triple circle was rotating in a frenzy. Each time Lloyd spoke, the circles reverberated with each other. A faint smile appeared on his lips. Just then, the circles collided. He pointed his shovel to the sky.

Kaboom!

“...!”

The triple mana blast ejected out like a volcanic explosion, forming a straight line that traveled as high as 70 yards in the air. It burned a section of the night sky until it died down with the wind, which became hot due to the high temperature of the mana blast. It blew to dishevel Sir Blanc’s hair. Lloyd’s gaze traveled to the side, and he spoke, his voice serious and low.

“This is what real shoveling is all about.”

“...”

Sir Blanc remained silent. Not a single word managed to escape his mouth. In its stead, he gulped dryly. The following day, every single member of the White Cavalry modestly held up a shovel in their hands. And five days later, the second wave of monsters Lloyd had predicted showed up at the outskirts of the barony.

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Chapter 111: The Meaning of Shoveling (2)

Rumble...

The ground started to shake from the east, beyond the eastern range that soared high, from the abundant valleys in between the peaks to the rugged hills and nameless rocks under the ridge, and along the hunting site at the foot of the mountain, mine, logging area, road, and fields. There came an unfamiliar and heavy shaking of the ground. At last, it traveled past the horse hooves, going up through the back and armor and waist and chest.

“They are here.”

“Hmm.”

Sir Blanc nodded at the aide’s words. His green eyes traveled to the range east to the Frontera barony. The unfamiliar and thudding shaking was coming from there.

“Truly, are they Mastodons?”

Just then, Sir Blanc recalled the visit last night. Lloyd Frontera came to him.

“The Mastodons will sweep over our fiefdom probably tomorrow or the day after that.”

And so, Sir Blanc asked how on earth he knew about it. To that, Lloyd simply smiled and said that it was obvious.

Obvious? How did he predict that?

He couldn’t comprehend it. As far as he knew, Lloyd didn’t dispatch a patrol team to the eastern range. For the past few days, Lloyd was solely focused on supervising the construction. And yet, he acted as though he had a third eye watching everything. So, it was difficult for Sir Blanc to trust his prediction right away. It was still the case this early morning. After

breakfast time, Sir Blanc scoffed at the predicament as he washed his face. See? Nothing is happening, he had told himself that.

But now, he knew his doubts had been unnecessary. When it was noon, as if Lloyd and the monsters had struck a deal, there came from the distant mountain range in the east a low yet heavy shaking of the ground. It was the type of shaking that came when a hoard of heavy animals marched in unison, fearlessly shattering every tree and rock that stood in their way. There could only be one thing that could produce such vibration, and it was the flock of Mastodon, the giant herbivore that lived in the wilderness.

Judging by the intensity of the ground shaking, it looks like they will show up soon.

A 13-foot monster that looked like a mix of rhinoceros and elephant. Hundreds of them would hurtle into this place soon.

That's the way the Mastodons move.

Clench! Sir Blanc gripped the lance hard. Internally, he predicted how the coming battle would unfold.

The herd will come from the east to the west, charging into the barony right away. So the most efficient response on our part with the given capability is a head-on fight.

The White Cavalry would take the front and hurtle right toward the herd of charging Mastodons. They would pierce their frontal leg joint after dodging their tusks and horns.

It's important to block the one in the very front in order to disrupt and confuse the entire rest of the herd. That would naturally bring a stop to their stampede.

From then on, the knights would circle around the herd of immobilized Mastodons and gallop round and round, killing them with the lances. Like peeling an onion, those monsters would be killed one by one until the entire herd was slaughtered.

It’s fully possible. We can pull it off if the soldiers in the Frontera barony offer us proper support and stay within the file.

Sir Blanc predicted in his head how the battle would end.

The herd of Mastodon will be massacred to the hilt. As for us, the White Cavalry... We will lose around 20 to 30 knights.

About 30 casualties among the 500. It was a considerable amount of damage. But Sir Blanc clamped his mouth shut.

It doesn’t matter. If that is the result of our best efforts, so be it. I’ll be content. For that is our honor.

This battlefield was chosen under the orders of the monarch. They were now protecting the land from the invasion of monsters. And so, death was not to be feared in such battles.

“Everyone, get ready to take charge. We shall remain here on standby until we receive a signal. That’s when we move forward at once.”

“Yes, sir!”

500 knights of the White Cavalry, who were in the middle of the fiefdom, loudly responded in harmony. They held up the white lance at the same time. Just then, a messenger appeared in the distance, rushing toward Sir Blanc. He was sent by the baron to share the message that caught Sir Blanc by surprise.

“Whew!” the messenger panted when he arrived. “I have the order from the baron... Every single man of the White Cavalry is to leave this place at once and stand by near the southern border of the Maritz land with a lance and shovel.”

“What?” Sir Blanc’s beard quirked in disdain. “What do you mean that we should wait at the southern border? What about the charge?”

“The baron orders that direct confrontation must be avoided at all costs.”

“Then how’s he going to-”

“Do you,” the messenger said, “see the white rock on the ridge in the east?”

“Yes.”

“Master Lloyd is over there.”

“Lloyd Frontera? What is he doing over there?”

“He will be commanding the operation from there. He directed you to take over the designated location in the south and wait until you see the blue flag go up on the rock over there. That is when you must make a ‘slow’ procession toward the north,” the messenger explained.

“Slow? But we are up against Mastodons. Are you sure he didn’t mean to gallop at full speed or relentlessly charge forward?” Sir Blanc said in disbelief.

“Yes, I am sure. He instructed you to proceed slowly as you produce a thick sandstorm and drum the lance with your shovel for distraction.”

“But why...”

Sir Blanc’s face turned stoic and cold. The whole thing was absurd. *How could the baron call for a slow procession when we are facing the Mastodons? And what? Make dust and noise instead of roaring as we charge ahead?*

“Are you utmost certain that you received the proper order?” Sir Blanc asked incredulously.

“Yes, sir,” the messenger assured, “I am certain. Oh, Master Lloyd sent another message which he emphasized that I must relay it to you.”

“Must relay it to me? What could it be?”

“‘The time has come for the six-day shoveling to pay off.’ was his message.”

“...”

Sir Blanc’s mouth shut itself as he recalled the shoveling they had done the past six days.

“I see... I shall follow the order.”

“Thank you, sir. Well then.”

The messenger bowed and went away. Sir Blanc led his men right away, and throughout the southward travel, he cocked his head to the side in confusion.

Will the operation be effective?

A piece of memory interrupted his mind just then. It was probably one night about a week ago. Lloyd’s shovel fired an outburst of mana that shot straight for dozens of yards. Sir Blanc had never seen anything like it. It seemed more powerful than the aura of a sword master Sir Blanc had seen a couple of times. And with that, he lost the bet. Afterward, he grabbed the shovel per the request of Lloyd, making sure that his men did the same thing. Just like that, they moved according to his instructions.

And we shoveled... for six days straight.

That was all they really did. They laid the ground as ordered. They dug as they were instructed. They transferred soil, stacked it up, and flattened it. At first, no one could guess what they were constructing. But four days passed to reveal the outline of the result of their toil.

It was a massive sculpture installed on a surface.

A 492 x 328-foot flat surface, which was sloped by 15 degrees to the west, was built at first. After that, the shoveling continued. They transferred the volcanic ash to the soil ground. It was covered and flattened. Next, they either scraped or thickened the ground, depending on Lloyd’s instruction. Sometimes, they poured water to solidify the soil. This process continued to

slowly build up a gigantic image of a monster. The mammoth herbivore “Megalania” inhabits the wilderness.

So I went up to Lloyd and complained.

That this won’t work. This wasn’t a proper defense. When Sir Blanc explicitly questioned him, Lloyd responded...

“Doing so will be more effective for defense than stacking up a wall with the same amount of soil. I’m sure about it this time.”

But Sir Blanc wasn’t convinced. That carved-out image on the surface would block a herd of Mastodons?

And not enough with that, he now prevents us from charging straight into the herd. What in the world is he thinking?

Sir Blanc was tormented throughout his journey to the south. For the cavalry, the timing to rush toward the enemy was never random. In fact, finding the perfect timing was actually more important when they were fighting against monsters. Lloyd was about to waste such a golden opportunity for reasons Sir Blanc could not grasp.

He’s not doing this because of some superstition, is he?

Sir Blanc nibbled his lips, and his gaze, which contained an abundance of concern, moved toward the white rock where Lloyd was.

This plan. I wonder if it will be effective.

***

“Effective? Of course, it is.”

Lloyd chuckled, convinced that everything would take place exactly the way he predicted. Much like his prediction that Mastodon would be the second wave of the monsters to charge into the barony.

“Were you confident about all this?” It was Javier who asked.

“Yeah.” Lloyd nodded his head.

“But how could you be so convinced?” asked Javier.

“Simple. I am smart.”

Javier ignored Lloyd.

“Just kidding. I looked through some documents,” Lloyd stated.

“Documents?”

“Yeah, this one.”

Lloyd tapped an old booklet and dusted off its cover. Javier noticed that the leathery cover was entitled “Illustrations of Monsters in the Eastern Wilderness.”

“I found this in the study. It organized the list of the monsters and their nature. So I read and took notes of the content,” Lloyd said.

“And the result is today’s operation?” asked Javier.

“Yeah.”

Lloyd nodded eagerly, but the truth was that he was lying. He did refer to a book. But that illustrated book wasn’t the only book he had referred to.

Truth be told, there is another very useful book. The Knight of Blood and Iron. Haha.

The illustrated book he had told Javier about actually fell short of being a solid reference for him to devise a plan. But there was a reason why he had lied to Javier.

Because I need clear proof and reason for being smart.

It was only natural. Groundless ingenuity. Mysterious smarty-pants. Lloyd couldn’t afford to be viewed in such ways. What would happen if he acted

as if he knew everything about this place when there was nothing for him to study? What would happen if he got everything right about the future as though he was Sherlock Holmes? At first, he might get praised. But it would be different later on.

People would become suspicious of me eventually. They aren't fools.

As such, Lloyd regarded that his ingenuity should be backed by something that people in this world could easily accept.

It's convenient to live free from suspicion.

A suspicion-free fiefdom. A life full of trust. Lloyd believed in that motto. So, he spoke.

"I must have told you before that this is happening because of the monster domino phenomenon. Just imagine what monsters would come after the locusts. It's obvious. Those that live in a herd, mobilize fast, are at the bottom of the food chain, and are strong enough to climb over the eastern range."

"Mastodons," Javier said.

"Yes, that's it."

That was as far as Lloyd referred to in the illustrated book. The following preparation and planning were based on *The Knight of Blood and Iron.*

After all, he wasn't a genius. He was not Sherlock Holmes, either. He just had a bit more access to information. That was the only upper hand Lloyd had compared to the people here.

Anyway, the short mention of the hunting custom by the orcs in the novel helped me a lot.

Lloyd recalled in the novel. Orc tribes used an enormous plate of Megalania when they hunted down the Mastodons. And being brainless and cautious beasts, the Mastodons judged that the plate was the real Megalania and ran away to the other side just in case. They took precautions first before

judging. Orcs smartly made good use of their nature by installing the traps in the direction those monsters rush ahead to for safety.

“So watch how the trap is set from now on. Watch closely.”

Lloyd pointed to the side with his chin. Just then, the ground shaking amplified by a notch. It became nearer. Hundreds of trees in the area shook and fell. At last, the herd of Mastodons appeared.

“Gwoahhh!”

Crash! Rumble!

A 13-foot body with a horn of a rhinoceros, tusk of an elephant, and a head of a bison. The Mastodon. Hundreds of the monsters came rampaging down the foot of the eastern range. They crossed the hunting and logging site, trampling on the fields. In particular, the one in the far front, the leader of the herd, thought to itself as it breathed out heavily. It felt nice to stampede on a flat surface after climbing the range. And unlike the wilderness, there were nice patches of greenery here and there. And for the time being, they didn’t have to worry about the incoming mating season as they could happily run around the grass to their heart’s content. The leader Mastodon glared at the barony, its eyes bloodshot. And at last, it saw.

“Gwoak...?”

Right in the middle of the human fiefdom. It saw the image of its archenemy there. The horrendous predator Megalania, whose staple was very themselves. Its mouth was elongated like a crocodile. Fangs stuck out in between its lips. Skin so thick that their horns couldn’t penetrate into it. And its claws were made special for tearing the belly skin of its prey. The double whammy was that the Megalania standing over there was at least three times bigger than what the Mastodons had in mind. Moreover, it sat crouching to its side, which was a hunting position distinct to Megalania!

“Gwoa! Gwoak!”

The leader Mastodon was taken aback and couldn’t figure out what the Megalania was doing in human territory. It couldn’t believe it. But at the same time, it couldn’t deny what it was seeing. That was how lifelike the Megalania sculpture covered up in the soil and volcanic ash was. It looked as if the Megalania would pounce and snap its back in one chomp. The leader Mastodon was terrified even though it thought that the Megalania could be fake. But when it considered the slim possibility that the predator was indeed real, fear swept over its whole existence. It didn’t want to die. Eventually, the leader made the decision to opt for safety, which was in line with its nature.

“Gwoack! Oak!”

Slide! Halt!

The Mastodon stopped in its tracks to the west. The same went for the rest of the herd that followed behind. And just like that, dismay and chaos descended on the herd as they were lost in direction. It was just then…

“Now! Raise the blue flag!” shouted Lloyd.

Javier lifted the huge flag. The blue flag swayed over the white rock. Sir Blanc, who was waiting at the entrance of the southern part of the Maritz land, saw it clearly.

The operation worked? I never thought the Mastodons would stop at the image etched on the ground...

Sir Blanc was clueless, indeed. This was true even when he had been shoveling for the construction.

Is it because of the slope toward the east?

The ground was sloped up by 15 degrees. The Mastodons charged down from the range, which meant that they were gazing downward. So, those two angles must have compounded to make the image more real and lifelike in the eyes of the bison-like beasts. Sir Blanc postulated such. But he

immediately snapped out of his reverie as he had a job to do right now. Thinking of the order he had received, he shouted...

“We shall march forward! Hold up your shovels and lances!”

Clip clop! Clip clop!

The 500 lancers moved, clip-clopping and trotting as they moved forward under the order. They marched, each of their steps creating as much sand dust as per the prior command. And they didn’t forget to clang the lance and shovel aloud with both of their hands.

Clang! Clash! Clang!

They slowly progressed toward the north, creating a loud cacophony. This brought about an unexpected reaction from the herd of Mastodons.

“Gwoack!”

The leader cried out at length, and it started to dart off to the north.

Is the threat working?

The monsters were now on the run. Unbeknownst to Sir Blanc, the Mastodons would have shown an opposite reaction from the current one if Sir Blanc had opted to stick with his initial plan of hurtling toward them. The knights’ excessive threat would have awakened the defensive instinct of the monsters and prompted them to fight back. But now, it was different. The knights pressured the Mastodons just with the sand, dust, and noise. It worked very well. The Megalania in the distance stirred fear among the Mastodons. And the nearing sandstorm and din. The two things work together to push those monsters to run away.

Hold on. There is a connected passageway dug deep in the north and south... Where the monsters are heading now... No way.

Sir Blanc was enlightened at last. What lay in the destination of these charging Mastodons was the very place he and his knights shoveled their heads off for the last six days. Certainly, they didn’t shovel out the ground

with a certain purpose in mind. They simply followed Lloyd’s instructions. They dug and filled as told. Just like that, they shoveled out the soil to make the foundation of the Megalania image. But the result? There came about a long and deep hole that was likened to a canal.

But that hole... its southern and northern end almost touched the river that flowed by the Maritz land... Wait a minute. Did he really...?!

Just then, a hunch flashed through his mind, and things started to piece together. One by one, each piece was assembled and jumbled to reveal the final picture. The trap. Sir Blanc shuddered as the epiphany struck his mind. He turned toward the white rock on the eastern mountain range. A white flag was waving as though it was confirming his prediction. Then he immediately noticed a fantastical creature, which was likened to the summon creature, that rolled from the south toward the herd of the Mastodons.

“Hamang!”

And there began the water attack.

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Chapter 112: Conqueror of the Fountain (1)

Water jetted out, filling up the water bottle.

Trickle.

“Here, drink this, sir.”

Sir Blanc was snapped out of his trance to find his aide holding out a portable water bottle.

“It’s water, sir,” his aide said, “I thought your throat might be coarse from inhaling all the dust.”

“Oh, thank you,” Sir Blanc said as he took the bottle. As the bottle tilted sideways in his hands, the water inside flowed through his throat. Just then, a certain image came to his mind. The Mastodon herd. The straight route. The column of water. A giant hippopotamus rolling and jetting out water. The hundreds of beasts swam away in sheer terror at the image and force of the creature.

“...”

The cold water absorbed into his empty stomach. The water attack had been impressive and effective as it swept away the entire herd of countless Mastodons. The flood shoved them to the end of the route toward the northern river.

How can I make sense of what I saw today...?

Sir Blanc asked himself whether what he saw was real. Or was it a terrible dream? Or was a giant scheme at play here? He couldn’t tell which one it was. But there was something certain, and it was that Lloyd Frontera’s plan had worked, saving the barony from a rampage of hundreds of Mastodons without seeing almost any damage.

“Oh, there was some damage.”

Sir Blanc heard a voice coming from beside him, but it didn’t belong to his aide. He turned and found Lloyd Frontera smiling in a wry way distinct from the latter. Sir Blanc wondered when he had come here.

Feeling slightly dazed, Sir Blanc asked, “There was damage?”

“Yes. There was.”

Lloyd shrugged his shoulders, replying in a deprecating manner.

“The fields in the mountain foot have been ruined. That was where we planted the onions, green onions, potatoes, and corn. What a waste, really. The corn in that particular field was very tasty.”

“...”

“Oh, and a portion of the paved road was lost as the flood swept the Mastodons. It really was some tough work building that up. But what else can we do? We have to repair it again.”

Sir Blanc was left speechless. Lloyd Frontera should be receiving a medal for minimizing the damage from the attack of several hundreds of Mastodons. But instead, the man was making a big fuss about relatively trivial losses. Who was this guy?

“Wait a second. The flood attack and the waterway for that, no, the underground route the Mastodons ran into by themselves and swam off for their lives... Was that all in your head when we were constructing the image of the Megalania?” Sir Blanc asked reflexively”

“Of course,” Lloyd answered plainly without any trivial modesty or humility.

“It was tough digging for six days straight, right? It was all part of the plan. I am sure you complained and wondered why I made you dig and move soil when you could always shovel the area right beside the relief image. Well, that was all part of the plan, too. You were annoyed for having to dig

following a straight, designated course when you could just dig up one area, right? Of course, that was also part of the plan," said Lloyd.

"Then the course of the waterway was-"

"Yes, everything was designed after a survey to make use of the Prona River that flows down clockwise as it hugs the barony from the south to the north."

"..."

"Starting from the point the course of the river breaks westward to the north. To converge it with the downstream that flows after traveling clockwise. Well, thanks to this job, we built up one more waterway we can utilize down the road. All we need is just some repairs and maintenance, and it can be used as a mini canal."

Killing two birds with one stone. Getting a free parking spot after only purchasing a bag of candy. Obtaining a canal after protecting the Mastodon invasion. All of these were made possible because of the foolish yet careful nature of the Mastodon.

"Well, anyway, the Mastodons should live well now that they are swept to the north. They aren't going to die so easily by the flood anyway. And since the north is an uninhabited region, it's not likely for them to come back here."

"How do you know that they will not come back...?"

"Because they already laid their eyes on the Megalania, their natural enemy."

"Oh," Sir Blanc gaped.

"Those beasts will remember everything very well. And so, they won't be coming here where their natural enemy lives. It'd make more sense for them to avoid this place."

"Did you calculate that all in your head?"

“Yes, of course. Isn’t it obvious?”

“...”

Sir Blanc was left speechless because it wasn’t obvious to him. He had thought that the best solution was fighting and repelling them off. He had thought that he should simply protect the kingdom’s territory by throwing his life away like it was a worthless trinket.

But we won without a fight, with almost any loss”

No, they even gained something. The fiefdom attained a canal they could use in the future. Sir Blanc wondered how many trials and errors Lloyd Frontera underwent to draw this result. How hard he must have racked his brain to turn his plan into reality. Since he was just a brawn knight, Sir Blanc couldn’t imagine it at all. His Adam’s apple jerked by reflex, and he suddenly thought to himself...

Maybe this is what real combat is all about.

It turned out that rushing toward the enemy wasn’t the magic formula to victory. Parading around in courage wasn’t the answer. Victory ought to be clinched without fighting. Practical benefits must be attained thoroughly. Sir Blanc pondered whether those two were the actual victories he ought to pursue as a commanding knight.

That way, I won’t have to lose my men.

Sir Blanc recalled the countless battles he had fought. He had gone through 12 wars as a member of the White Cavalry. Then, five more after he became the commander of the lancers, including this one. So throughout the 17 occasions of small and large battles, this was the first time he had not lost any men. This time, he didn’t have to clean up the corpses of his men, which had developed into a habit after every battle. This unfamiliar and fresh experience made his heart beat faster, leaving him with an important lesson.

Yes, I used to mask death with valor and honor. I had considered it an honor to fight courageously and die. But here, there was greater valor and honor. To fight and live. To safely return to our families, loved ones, and friends after a battle, so that we can fight a bigger one.

To continue to stay alive and grow stronger and overcome bigger battles. And along the way, protect the country as well as families and their happiness along the way.

That was the way to uphold my honor all the more.

How foolish he had been! And how many men he could have saved had he realized this sooner. Regret, shock, and realization rushed over him. At the same time, he lifted his head and gazed at Lloyd differently.

“Thank you,” Sir Blanc said.

“Excuse me?” Lloyd returned a confused gaze.

“Please take good care of us moving forward,” Sir Blanc uttered, his voice dripping with respect.

Sir Blanc would watch and learn by Lloyd’s side. He would be further enlightened and educated. Just like that, he would consider this respectable man as his teacher.

“Oh, sure. Well, me too.”

Suppressing the awkwardness rising in him, Lloyd held out his hand, and the two shook hands. Sincerity was exchanged. Sir Blanc fought to not break into tears. Lloyd tightened his fingers that were trying to curl in the cringiness of this situation. And just like that, the day they stopped the second monster attack passed.

***

A few days passed. The repair job in the barony happened fast. They repaired the destroyed fields and redid the paved road washed away by the flood. But it didn’t come without a prize. When the herd of Mastodons

jumped into the water to be swept away out of fear, they left five Mastodon babies, which Sir Bayern had discovered.

“So... are you saying you wish to raise them?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

Sir Bayern reported with a deep resolution, and five Mastodon babies let out a loud cry as though they were responding to his voice.

Chu!

“Do you see it, Master Lloyd? Thankfully, every one of them is healthy and strong.”

“Yes, I can see that,” Lloyd replied, “but don’t you think it’s going to be dangerous?”

“They won’t be.”

“How would you know that?”

“Because they are adorable.”

“...”

Sir Bayern pointed at the Mastodon babies, but for some reason, Lloyd noticed that Sir Bayern’s face blushed a little contrary to his usual dignified state.

“There is a story I was told once. I heard that full-grown Mastodons raised in the wild are extremely violent around humans, but they are poles apart when you raise them from when they are babies.”

“Are you saying that they can be tamed?” Lloyd asked.

“That’s what I heard.”

“So, are you planning on raising them?”

“Yes.”

“Hmm, don’t you think it will be extremely difficult?”

“It won’t be.”

“How would you know that?”

“Because they are adorable,” said Sir Bayern as he cleared his throat. A large feeding bottle was already in his hand. But it wasn’t exactly a feeding bottle. It looked more like he attached a nipple on a small barrel.

“Chu!!”

“Chu!!”

The Mastodon babies, who were the size of a calf, fought to eat first from the feeding bottle. Sir Bayern snorted in satisfaction each time, feeding them the bottle one by one.

Well, well. Sir Bayern, I didn’t know you loved raising pets that much because of the dignified air around you.

Lloyd was slightly nauseated to see a grown man coo at the baby animals and be overwhelmed by happiness, but he decided that it wasn’t a bad thing.

“Hmm. So, you want my permission?” Lloyd asked”

“Yes, please.”

“Hmm, what should I do?”

Sir Bayern waited nervously for the decision. Lloyd thought about it as he looked at Sir Bayern. Mastodon was a herbivore monster reaching up to 13 feet in height. And it showed extraordinary power matching its size. So if Sir Bayern successfully tamed them, they would be set to become a great asset to the fiefdom. They could be a great source of labor for many different chores and projects.

We can make them work in a field, carry heavy loads, or draw a giant carriage. Put them together, and we may have a pollution-free engine locomotive. But they would be excreting massive amounts of feces, much more than cows. That’d be the downside.

Lloyd concluded that there were infinite ways to use them.

“Sure. Raise them well, Sir Bayern.”

“Do you really mean it?”

“If not, would I lie about it?”

“No. Thank you. Okay, Pudding, Puddang, Pungdeong, Pungding, and Pudong. Line up, and greet him. He is Master Lloyd, your master from now on,” Sir Bayern introduced.

“Chu!!”

“Chu!!”

Woah, he named them already...? He really was bent on raising them all up. My goodness, he would have been really upset if I didn’t give my permission.

Lloyd smiled wryly and left him. Even after that, he took care of several things. He picked out the civil engineers who crossed the eastern range with him. And he sent them back over to the eastern range to make run surveillance of the area and check the safety of orc tribes.

I didn’t have the time to do it until now, even though I wanted to.

The previous situations had demanded every second of focus from Lloyd. A moment of distraction was a luxury for him. But now, since he could breathe and relax somewhat, he decided to attempt something he had wanted to try all along but never had the time for.

“Did you hear what I said? You just have to stand still there,” announced Lloyd”

“Right here?”

“Yeah.”

“Does that mean that you will be absorbing a large amount of mana like you explained?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, I will.”

Lloyd wanted to see if he could level up like the time he supercharged his mana heart by absorbing the mana of Queen Magentano in Magentano the capital. So now, Lloyd and Javier were in the training hall in the middle of the night.

“But, Master Lloyd…”

“Yeah, what?”

“But I just became a sword master.”

“Yeah, so?”

“I can now sleep without your lullaby.”

“Aha. So you are no longer suffering from the sword master syndrome. Is that what you want to say?”

“Yes, I can adjust my overly sensitive senses now.”

“So since you have nothing to lose, you don’t want to be used and taken advantage of by me anymore?”

“Yes,” Javier said proudly.

“Do you really think so?”

“Excuse me?”

“Well, go try to sleep on your own tonight,” Lloyd suggested.

Lloyd smiled, brimming with confidence. That same night, when Javier went to bed, he tossed and turned throughout the night, unable to fall asleep. That was when he realized how scary habits were. His body was so accustomed to Lloyd's lullaby that he could not fall back asleep without it.

"So stay still for me, will you?" proposed Lloyd.

"Yes..."

It was the night after that. Javier was now flopped to the ground of the training hall, smothering the rage burning inside him. At last, Lloyd fired a triple mana blast in the air. He made himself worn out on purpose and activated the Supercharge optional skill. But the attempt failed, and Lloyd could not absorb large amounts of mana as he did from Queen Magentano. The reason was simple. Javier possessed the Asrahan Core Technique just as he did.

Ding Dong.

[Your opponent's mana circle is reverberating with yours, interrupting the flow of the mana absorption.]

The message appeared in front of his eyes and canceled his mana absorption from Javier. Because of that, Lloyd sucked the mana only from the sand and air of the training hall, just enough to restore the amount of energy he had used up.

"Tsk... You useless punk."

Lloyd was disappointed, so for a split second, he mulled over the plan of raising Sir Blanc to the level of a sword master and turning him into his personal mana battery. But sadly, he just didn't have the time for that. The locusts and Mastodons were just the beginning of the monster domino phenomenon that was about to crash down on them.

"But we won't last if we stop every single one of them. It's a war of attrition, and a meaningless one."

The following night, Lloyd gathered everyone at the baron's office. The baron and baroness, Javier, Sir Bayern, and Sir Blanc sat at the table. Standing in front of them, Lloyd revealed the grand plan he had been developing for a long while. It was a smart measure to put a stop to this monster domino once and for all and acquire permanent peace.

"All we need to do is go to Lake Kapua and wake King Storma, the ruler of the area, and make him work for us. I already have a detailed plan for that. What do you think? Isn't it simple?"

Everyone in the room gulped dryly, and as the future grew bleak in their minds, they wondered to themselves if there was anything difficult for Lloyd.

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Chapter 113: The Conqueror of the Fountain (2)

“Lake Kapua? The one that sits in the middle of the eastern range? Are you saying you plan on waking King Storma who rules over the area?”

The baron broke the silence in the room. His urgent question pierced everyone’s ears, and it was only then that they were jostled out of their trance. The baroness found herself clutching her handkerchief. Javier’s blue eyes flashed coldly while Sir Bayern gulped dryly. Sir Blanc’s heart jumped in expectation. Baron Frontera tossed the question again.

“Isn’t Lake Kapua the place where you constructed the intake station for the waterway because of Viscount Lacona?”

“Yes, it is,” Lloyd said.

“And isn’t sleeping King Storma a formidable monster?”

“Yes, that is right as well,” answered Lloyd again.

“Do you have a special purpose in mind as to why you want to wake up such an evil monster?”

“Yes, it is the one I told you about a while ago.”

“What do you mean you told us already?”

“I plan on making him work for us.”

“King Storma? Do you mean to wake him up and put him to work?”

“Yes,” Lloyd answered, his voice sounding assured.

“...”

How is that possible? What kind of job does he plan to give to a monster?

The baron and the others felt dazed by Lloyd's words as they were completely in the dark about his plan. Meanwhile, Lloyd continued to speak.

"Well, I am planning on putting him to work, but it is nothing grand. Twice a day. Morning and night. I will make him roar."

"Roar?"

"Yes, it can be understood as an act of marking his territory."

"The roar of King Storma. Will it change anything?"

"Yes, there will be a large change."

"Could you be more specific?" asked the baron.

"The barony will not be damaged by the monster domino phenomenon."

"How so?"

"The monsters rushing to the west from the wilderness will never dare traverse the eastern range," Lloyd reasoned.

"Wait, because of King Storma's roar?"

"Yes," Lloyd said as he nodded. He then fished an old booklet out of his embrace.

"This is an old record I found in the study."

Crunch. Crunch Lloyd carefully flipped open the booklet, its old paper giving off a moldy smell.

"Please take a look at this. About 350 years ago, that is, before our family was bestowed this fiefdom, a lord that used to rule over the province left a record."

Lloyd pointed to one page.

“The record shows that King Storma arrived at the mountain range at that time. No one knows where he came from. But the record shows that he was very active at that time. He chopped countless trees and brought them to the middle of the mountain range.”

“To the middle of the mountain range? Why?”

Lloyd grinned at the baron’s question.

“To make a natural dam. And so, a huge volume of water stagnated in the middle of the mountain range on and on, and I am sure you can guess what comes next, right? The origin of Lake Kapua.”

“Oh...”

Everyone’s eyes broadened when they found out that Lake Kapua wasn’t a natural occurrence. It was formed by King Storma. They started to give more ears to Lloyd.

“Well, it’s not a surprise that you never heard of it. I, too, learned about it for the first time from this record. Anyway, soils piled, and trees grew on the dam, eventually transforming the scenery into the natural mountain lake it is right now. And King Storma went into hibernation in satisfaction in the center of the lake he had created.”

“So, are you telling us that Lake Kapua was created to make a home for the monster? By King Storma himself?”

“Yes, but what we must pay attention to is what follows.”

Flip. Flip.

Lloyd flipped the pages some more.

“According to the records, life in this part of the region turned rougher following King Storma’s hibernation.”

“How so?”

“Simple. Monsters came here, crossing over to the range from the east. They caused trouble, ate people, and so on. You know, the same events we experience once or twice a year at the foot of the mountain.”

“Oh...”

A glimmer appeared in the baron’s eyes. Listening to his son, the baron naturally understood. The Frontera Barony, at times, fell victim to intermittent monster attacks. Most of them were the attacks of the monsters coming down from the eastern range. It had always been a problem here, even before the monster domino phenomenon. But what would happen if a giant monster started to become active in Lake Kapua, which sat along the range down to their fiefdom? The answer was crystal clear.

“So, are you thinking that King Storma will deter the monsters?” asked the baron.

“Yes, that’s exactly what I think,” replied Lloyd.

“That’s why you want to wake King Storma up?”

“Indeed. Once he roars twice a day to mark his territory, the monsters coming from the east will naturally turn back in fear. He would be likened to a biological wall to put it one way,” Lloyd explained.

“A biological wall...” the baron said as he nodded his head.

Everyone shared the same sentiment about this idea. Lloyd’s suggestion was more than what they imagined. But it was convincing, and it was worth giving it a try.

“But don’t you think this is too dangerous?” asked the baron.

“By dangerous, you mean...”

“I am talking about the chance of King Storma storming into our fiefdom and attacking us,” the baron said in a faintly concerning voice. “Should that formidable creature charge at our fiefdom, the damage will be catastrophic. D you have any measures in plan to avoid such a mishap?”

“Of course I do,” Lloyd said with confidence.

“What is it?”

“Staying still,” Lloyd replied.

“Staying still?”

“That’s right,” affirmed Lloyd.

“How?”

“Just doing nothing. Staying still.”

The baron remained silent.

Lloyd smiled faintly.

“I mean it. This record tells me that King Storma never ever left his habitat. He manifested a highly territorial quality. I believe the same thing will happen again,” Lloyd reasoned.

“However, should something were to happen-”

“Yes, I know what you mean and are worried about. But we have Sir Asrahan with us.” Lloyd looked at Javier.

“What?” The baron looked at Lloyd, confused.

“As you know already, he is a sword master.”

Everyone’s gaze traveled to focus on Javier, who must have become embarrassed. He forced out some coughs. Lloyd smiled in a mischievous way.

“If King Storma storms into the fiefdom to wreak havoc on us, the answer is simple. We have Sir Asrahan, a sword master. Moreover, we are joined by the brave White Cavalry. Regardless of how powerful the monster is, we should be able to hunt him down with ease,” Lloyd assured.

It was true. Lloyd studied King Storma by reading several works of literature and scholarly journals of many scholars. He reached the conclusion that the barony's current capabilities would be enough to hunt down the monster.

"We expect that King Storma will be as powerful as the Gigatitan we went up against back in Cremo," Lloyd continued. "So, if our goal is just hunting it down and nothing else, Sir Asrahan should be able to fight it alone. He could even kill it. It would be much easier than hundreds of thousands of locusts or hundreds of Mastodons. There would only be one opponent to go against."

"But our goal is not hunting but to make him work for us?" asked the baron.

"That's right. It appears that this is the best measure we have in our hands right now," reasoned Lloyd.

"Hmm... It does appear so." The baron nodded. Lloyd's explanation allowed him to visualize the plan in his head. In summary, King Storma wasn't that difficult to take care of on the off chance he went berserk and threatened the fiefdom. And if they achieved the goal, King Storma was set to effectively deter a large number of peskier monsters from dealing with than King Storma himself. Controlling him wasn't that hard, and yet, he efficiently blocked bigger threats. That was what King Storma was to the barony.

"In short, he would be a gigantic guard dog. A guard dog on a leash in our front yard that scares and deters other monsters," said the baroness, who had been quietly listening to the conversation.

Come to think of it, King Storma was certainly set to be a guard dog. It was a good summary. Thanks to her analogy, everyone was able to get a clearer picture of Lloyd's plan. But that didn't mean that everyone didn't have any questions.

"Hmm, I somehow see it now. But I wonder..." The baron muttered as he cocked his head to the side. "How do you plan on waking him up and controlling him at your disposal?"

“We won’t be controlling him,” answered Lloyd.

“Then?”

“We’ll put him to exercise.”

Lloyd brought his hand to the old booklet, turning the pages until it landed on the last one.

“Take a look here.”

Everyone’s eyes followed Lloyd’s fingers, which were pointing at the sentence that defined King Storma.

[Very similar to a beaver.]

“A beaver...?”

Everyone tilted their heads to the side with the exemption of Sir Blanc, who thus spoke.

“A beaver is a large animal that looks like a rat and lives in the river to make dams, right?”

“Very good. You are right, Sir Blanc. It appears that the others are not familiar with the animal,” said Lloyd as he smiled.

“It’s just like what Sir Blanc said. Beavers tend to make dams in the rivers or lakes by gathering up tree branches. They show a great obsession with dams. Sometimes, they create one from generation to generation. Therefore, when a dam is broken, they leave everything behind and try to make another one.”

“Are you saying,” said the baron, “that King Storma will be the same?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded his head as he recalled the time he watched a program about beavers back in South Korea.

In a TV program, I don't know, was it episode 202? It showed beavers raised in zoos.

Their daily life consisted of creating dams. They worked hard to build one. But once they succeeded, the zookeeper shattered and destroyed it to pieces without any mercy.

I thought the zookeeper was evil and abusing the animal. But that wasn't the case.

The zookeeper's interview came to Lloyd's mind. She said destroying the dams was a way to keep the wild nature of beavers. It kept them moving. If the dam was left all built and strong, the beavers accepted the reality and settled there. They got lazy and fat and sick. That was the rationale behind the constant demolition of their dams. Giving them work to do—that was the way to keep them industrious, mobile, and healthy.

Several scholars analyzed and concluded that King Storma was much like the beavers in that sense. So, this method will probably work as well.

Lloyd briefly walked them through about the nature of the beaver, excluding the part about the TV program. And around the time everyone started to nod in understanding, Lloyd spoke with confidence.

"As such, we just have to use that method as well."

"That method?"

"Yes, we will slightly destroy the edge of Lake Kapua while King Storma is asleep."

"And you think King Storma will wake up to repair the dam after feeling the damage?"

"That's exactly what I mean."

"What happens if the dam is all repaired?"

"We can sneak again and destroy it."

For a split second, everyone couldn’t find the words to respond. It was because they suddenly felt compassion toward King Storma, who was in hibernation. But Lloyd was indifferent to everyone’s gaze.

Right now, we just don’t have the time to mind that.

As of now, the fiefdom was on the verge of being swept away by the monster domino. So, if he could bring peace and wellness to the fiefdom by harassing a giant monster for about a year, Lloyd was ready to do it even a hundred times.

“Plus, you don’t have to feel compassion for King Storma. We have our own share of risks by waking him up.”

“Hmm, yes, since he surely is a giant monster.”

“Yes, and on top of that, we might cause a great flood if we destroy the dam after inaccurately calculating the demolition scope.”

“A great flood, eh?” asked the baron.

“Yes.”

Lloyd’s gaze turned serious.

“That is the thing with dams, just a tiny fraction is all it needs for the entire thing to be demolished. And more than the miscalculation, King Storma going berserk in the lake can cause trouble. That would cause a tsunami, overflowing the water out of the dam. Then there would be another flood,” stated Lloyd.

Everyone became speechless. They never ever thought about such a type of disaster.

Well, not so surprising that they’re speechless. I mean, they have never encountered a huge dam before.

But the two types of disasters he had used as an example held the possibility of happening anytime at the fiefdom.

First case was the demolition of the Stava dam in Italy in 1985. A little damage on the outer wall collapsed the entire dam, and about 66,000 gallons of water swept the village at the speed of 55 mph.

The second case, the lake tsunami, was worse.

In 1963, the Vajont dam collapsed. That was even more awful. The two sides of the dam contained a limestone and clay layer. And when the water level increased because of the dam, it touched this layer until the foundation weakened and created a landslide. 238 million square meters worth of soil slid into the dam all at once, whose impact power was twice the impact of the Hiroshima nuclear bomb.

The aftermath was horrifying. The large amount of soil fell out of the dam lake to create a mega-tsunami that soared as high as 820 feet. The shocking and terrorizing wave went over the dam, sweeping the entire village nearby. It was a mega catastrophe, with around 2,500 to 5,000 people losing their lives.

“But, well, attention must be paid to ensure that those disasters will not be happening here. You can leave that to me. Surveying and designing are perfect for a job like this.”

Lloyd planned to make meticulous calculations to avoid any damage to the dam when they awakened King Storma and put him to work by purposefully destroying a part of the dam. And he would also lead and design King Storma’s movement.

“And so, since King Storma is a dangerous monster, only Sir Asrahan, the White Cavalry, and I will be working on this job.”

“Us?” asked Sir Blanc.

Lloyd grinned and spoke.

“Yes, since the job is too risky for ordinary engineers to partake in. Even when King Storma notices us and acts up, your men will able to respond to him and get ready for combat.”

That would be something impossible for ordinary soldiers. There was a chance of massive casualty should King Storma go berserk. Thus, Lloyd needed strong men who could fight right away when things went south during the shoveling.

“So, this is the reason why I hurried to bring your men to the civil engineer corp and make the Megalania structure,” Lloyd went on. “Why, you ask? To make you all used to shoveling.”

“...”

Lloyd’s nonchalant voice rang aloud in the office. Everyone clamped their mouths shut. And soon, it hit them that Lloyd had been holding various projects with this very plan in mind. As such, everyone could only get on board with his plan, thereby kickstarting Lloyd’s evil and sly scheme of intentionally waking the sleeping ancient lake monster and taking advantage of him.

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Chapter 114: The Conqueror of the Fountain (3)

Splash.

Autumn must have arrived already. Lloyd withdrew his hand after he touched the lake water. It was colder than he thought. It was the same for the morning air”

It’s perfect weather to catch a cold.

After washing his face, Lloyd looked around the lake. Lake Kapua. It was a typical lake located in the mountains. But its size was obscenely vast. Because of the twisted and elongated terrain, his eyes couldn’t hold the whole area in one gaze.

I think it’s about the size of Lake Soyang.

Lake Soyang bordered Chuncheon, Yanggu, and Inje in Gangwon Province in South Korea. It was about 1,608 hectares in area, and its curve extended to about 1,200 yards. It was an expansive lake whose storage reached up to 2.9 billion tons.

I think this place would be just that.

Lake Soyang of South Korea and Lake Kapua in this mountain range. The two shared several similarities. First of all, they weren’t naturally formed. Lake Soyang was human-made, while Lake Kapua was constructed by King Storma. Due to the artificial construction, most of the lake water was stopped at a particular point.

If the stop gate for Lake Soyang was the Soyang dam, this place would be right there.

Lloyd gazed westward. His eyes were already glimmering from the faint wave of mana.

Ding Dong.

[Surveying skill has been activated.]

[Scanning will begin.]

Flash!

Lloyd studied the western side of the lake with a sharp eye. He closely looked at the geography and features of the area using his surveying skill.

This lake is basically a dam. If I had to compare, it kind of feels like a rockfill dam."

A rockfill dam was different from a regular concrete gravity dam. While the latter was constructed by pouring concrete, a rockfill dam was composed of a mix of rock, pebbles, sand, and other ingredients. The dam King Storma had built was exactly like that.

King Storma used large amounts of rocks and pebbles, and on top of that, he weaved together entire trees"

Lloyd activated the "Subterranean Scanning," which was an optional skill within the surveying skill. He then got a clear read on the components of the 16-foot deep underground. The inside of the dam was also made visible, albeit faintly. Though it wasn't a complete scan, he was able to tell that the dam was so well built that it looked like an impenetrable fortress.

King Storma ripped out humongous trees by their roots.

The trees were then piled up, numbering thousands and tens of thousands, and in between the frames, King Storma used a massive amount of pebbles, rocks, and sand to fill up any empty crevices left behind. And as years passed by, sand naturally accumulated on the surface. As grass and trees started to grow on top, their roots entangled with each other and firmly set themselves in place. This became a key feature of the terrain.

I don't even think dynamite is going to cut it.

Lloyd continued to be surprised as he laid his eyes on the lake. But he wasn't worried because, right now, destroying the whole dam wasn't his

goal. Doing so could actually cause several million gallons worth of water to flood this whole place. Right now, the goal was to destroy only a portion of the dam.

Just small enough to still keep the entire dam structure intact.

It would be imperative to carefully calculate his plan.

Splash! Splash! Lloyd washed his face with the lake water after collecting the data around the dam with the surveying skill. And when the coldness of the water settled his thoughts, Lloyd activated the survey design skill to test out the collected data.

Ding Dong.

[Skill Option 3: Simulation mode has been activated.]

[The topographical data in the current design space will be available for simulation.]

Bzzt! A virtual design space appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes, applying the data he acquired just now.

Flash!

All sorts of quantitative and qualitative data points of the area's physical characteristics were displayed in front of him. The height of the topography and the chemical composition. All of those elements were reflected in the design space. Lines were drawn. The sides were overlapped. Just like that, the western area of Lake Kapua appeared in the virtual space—no different from the actual one.

Let's begin.

Lloyd set about moving his hands, sometimes like a performer twanging a guitar string in arpeggio or tapping the piano key in staccato. Or like sliding the violin in glissando. Lloyd's two hands freely moved around the virtual space, pulling a point, expanding a line, and flipping a side. Low hills were dug. Rocks were separated. Holes were dug. Lloyd destroyed, repaired,

penetrated, and dug, repeating all sorts of tries and experiments. He ran all kinds of tests on almost all points of the dam that occupied the west of the lake. While that was happening, Lloyd was so engrossed in the job that he failed to notice the hard gaze coming from his side.

"..."

Javier quietly stared at Lloyd. He's doing it again, said Javier to himself. Lloyd was in a trance, yes, but it didn't look like he was meditating or was deep in thought. Instead, his eyes were glimmering brightly. He was busy scanning and staring into the distance. And his hands—they kept moving without a second of rest while his arms were busily outstretched in front of him.

Could it be that Master Lloyd can see something others can't see?

No matter how much Javier thought about it, that was the only explanation he could come up with. And that made Javier more perplexed.

Master Lloyd can see things even I cannot see?

Javier's neat eyebrows furrowed slightly. Of course, he had seen his young master do this several times before. But he had simply brushed it off, thinking that Master Lloyd sees and feels something he failed to see. After all, he wasn't a sword master. But right now, he learned that it wasn't the case.

When I became a sword master, my senses were perfected. And yet, I still can't feel or see anything, just like before.

Javier's senses transcended human capacity. He could pick up even the tiniest sound around him if he wanted. So much as a speck of dust and its energy could be sensed. And yet, he failed to pick up or see whatever it was that Lloyd saw at the moment. It was so even when he was right beside Lloyd.

What could it be?

Something visible to Lloyd but wasn’t to Javier. He racked his brain, but nothing came to his mind. It didn’t look like magic because he didn’t feel the mana.

A special power yet to be uncovered? Or is it just a habit he has when he focuses on something?

Pinch.

To test it out, Javier slightly pinched both sides of Lloyd’s cheeks. He then stood in front of Lloyd and waved his arms. But nothing. Lloyd didn’t react. With a focused expression and gaze, Lloyd kept on touching and waving in the air.

The more I learn about him, the harder it gets to make sense of him.

Lloyd Frontera. His young master. Javier wondered what this man was. He had thought he knew Lloyd well before. A hooligan young master who came to his senses.

But now, I can’t make sense of him anymore.

Despite the internal confusion Javier was going through, Lloyd remained focused on the design work. As Javier was staring at Lloyd, questions kept invading his thoughts. However, he willfully pushed them to the back of his mind, his blue eyes glimmering. Leaves, which were insensitive to his thoughts, kept falling to tap on his shoulders.

***

Three days passed, and the design was complete. At last, the demolition plan was finished.

“I am sure you know it already. Today, we will be demolishing a part of the dam that supports Lake Kapua.” Lloyd was standing in front of the 500 White Calvary, giving a speech”

“As such, everyone must be well aware of the goal of our job. Today, we are not destroying the whole dam. We will instead dig and break down just

the designated area. Now, each of you has worked together with my civil engineers, and today's job is the very reason that you familiarized yourselves with the shovel."

Lloyd continued talking.

"Some of you might ask, 'If the job involves shoveling only, why aren't the civil engineers of the fiefdom joining us?' That is an incorrect way of thinking. Their safety can never be guaranteed in this job. They will not be able to fend for themselves against King Storma that will be awakened by our demolition. They are not like you, the brave lances of the White Cavalry."

Lloyd traveled the length of the formation and pointed at each of them one by one.

"I have no inkling of doubt that you are all very different from the engineers. Even if King Storma wakes up and fights back during our job today, you can get right into combat with the shovel in hand as you are strong and brave warriors. Am I correct?"

"Yes, you are!"

Lloyd's obvious sweet talk was intentional, and it was meant to boost the ego of the lancers of the White Cavalry. They gradually started to feel happier hearing Lloyd's words.

"Yes, indeed. This job is made possible because you are with me. Clumsy knights and boastful warriors don't stand a chance against you. Who in the world would dare come down to this dangerous place to dig and wake such an epic evil monster and think to wield the shovel in the face of impending threats? Who else but the White Cavalry?! Am I right, or what?!"

"Wooo!!!"

"What are you?!" yelled Lloyd.

"The best of the best, the White Cavalry!"

“What’s the White Cavalry?!” yelled Lloyd once again.

“Valor! Honor! Bravery!”

“And we’ll do what today?!”

“Shoveling! With valor, honor, and bravery!”

At last, pride swelled among the lancers of the White Cavalry. It practically soared through the sky. Lloyd lifted his shovel high with a meaningful smile on his face and pointed at the demolition spot.

“Let’s go! Group one! Off you go!”

“Off we go!”

The shout kickstarted the demolition. The White Cavalry was overwhelmed with a soaring pride that all fears were driven out of them. Based on their overflowing stamina and valor, they shoveled continuously. And after the pep talk was over, Lloyd proceeded to grab the shovel by himself and move along with the group to actualize the demolition plan he had simulated countless times. Not a single thing deviated from the plan. The number of laborers was exact, and only the designated land mass was dug out. They stacked up with precision. The demolition was very detailed, so they went through the job with a fine-tooth comb to ensure that the lake water would not flood and that the structure would remain intact. Finally, Lloyd called Javier.

“Okay, just as I had explained to you,” said Lloyd, “Do you see the red marks drawn on four sides of the dam?”

“Should I break that area?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, using your mana blast. Make sure that it’s quick and clean at a perfect angle. Oh, and the spot will collapse right after it breaks, so run back here as soon as you hit it.”

“Does that mean I will be swept away by the rubbles if I escape late?” asked Javier.

“Yeah. Of course.”

“Will you then come to save me, Master Lloyd?”

“Why would I?”

“...”

“But I’ll make sure that you get compensated for the accident,” assured Lloyd.

“What are you saying...”

“And mourn your death anniversary. Not a year missed.”

“I... am still alive, Master Lloyd,” Javier griped.

“Well, just saying. Anyway, really, what are you waiting for? Go now. On the double.”

“Whew... I’ll go.”

Javier walked over to the demolition spot as he shook his head. The White Cavalry had courageously shoveled all throughout the morning. But now, the site was empty of people. Javier breathed heavily before drawing his sword.

“Hmm..”

Flash!

A ray of light flashed in his sword, and it penetrated the red mark. The ground trembled lightly. And by that time, Javier’s sword was already back to its sheath.

Kaboom!

A total of six mana blasts burst in a consecutive series. They uniformly penetrated and ruined the upper part of the dam after precisely following

their intended path. And they finally exploded.

Crash! Rumble!

Explosion and demolition. Intentional and measured destruction. Just like that, a portion of King Storma's dam crumbled for the first time in 300 years of its construction.

Rumble!

Hundreds of tons of piles of dirt and rocks slid down into the water, and its massive vibration shook the entire dam. But the dam remained solid, undestroyed. The same went for the lake trapped inside the dam.

It's working. I succeeded"

Lloyd clenched his hands as he threw his gaze to the center of the lake. A small island was sitting there, but it actually wasn't an island. Just like how beavers created their lodge by stacking up branches at the center of a lake, King Storma had built a massive nest at the center of his lake.

What about him?

Lloyd held a glint of nervousness in his eyes as he gazed at the nest. Today's project wasn't about the demolition. The objective was to demolish a part of the dam and wake the giant monster up and put him to work. That was the ultimate goal of mobilizing the White Cavalry in shoveling.

So stop sleeping and wake up, you sleepyhead. 300 years of hibernation is enough. It's time for you to get to work. Repair the broken dam. Mark your territory day and night. Stop the eastern monsters that will flood here like a domino.

Wishing such, Lloyd clenched his hands. He gulped and stared at King Storma's nest. Just then...

Wham!

The elevated nest that floated on the lake like an island... The huge trees that grew on its peak tumbled a little. A second later, it did once more.

Crash!

This time, the shake was a bit louder. Trees swayed back and forth in great motion.

Crash! Wham!

It now tumbled so hard that a willow tree fell. The same went for the upper part of the nest that supported the tree.

Thwack! Crash!

The entire nest rocked violently as though something giant woke up from its slumber and staggered half-asleep. And all of a sudden, something roared in horrifying terror as if it was letting out a griping grumble.

“Bibeong!”

Its vigor was so ferocious that it could upturn the whole world. But for some reason, the voice sounded similar to the cry of a fantastical creature in Lloyd’s ears. King Storma’s roar thundered through the lake.

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Chapter 115: Taming a Fantastical Creature (1)

“Bibeong!”

A thunderous cry rang aloud, shaking up the whole lake with force enough to turn the world upside down. Lloyd, who was hiding in the bush with the White Cavalry, was confused when he heard its cry.

Eh?

What is that? Why is it crying like that? It sounds so familiar. It sounds like a fantastical creature.

Just when Lloyd thought so, another ferocious outcry roared beneath the nest once again.

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

Fwoosh!

This time, his cry came louder. The clamorous noise created several ripples in the lake. The lancers of the White Cavalry reflexively tightened the shovel in their hands in nervousness. But Lloyd was different. He wasn’t nervous at all. He was rather curious and confused because of King Storma’s roar, which he could understand its meaning.

“Wait a minute. He just shouted, ‘Who broke my dam?!’ right? Did I hear it correctly?” asked Lloyd.

“Ppodong!”

When Lloyd asked Ppodong as he looked down at his embrace, Ppodong nodded his head hard.

“Ppo-do-dong. Ppodong. Ppo-do-dong!”

“Right?” confirmed Lloyd once more.

“Ppodong!”

“Yeah, it sounded like that to me too.”

Lloyd was absolutely certain about what King Storma said.

It was as if an automatic translator was lodged in my head when he spoke. His words were so clear and vivid. This feels so familiar.

It was only natural as he experienced it all the time. It was always like that when he talked to Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang.

So this is something I only experience when I’m chatting with fantastical creatures.

The mechanism behind the translation was a mystery to Lloyd as well because it just happened from the moment he had summoned Ppodong. For some inexplicable reasons, Ppodong’s language made clear sense to him as though a real-time translation tool was at work in his head or as though he was born with a top fantastical creature certification. He just could understand them.

But why is that happening right now?

King Storma was supposed to be an evil creature. So it was a wonder for Lloyd why the latter’s outcry sounded like that of a fantastical creature. Lloyd was jostled out of his curious state when he heard another ferocious roar.

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeo-beo-beo-beo-beong!”

Thwack!

A blare of noise thundered along with the roar. One side of the nest jerked upward, causing an explosive water spray. A gigantic shape slowly emerged to reveal a round and chubby silhouette that stood tall and high.

Splaaash!

The creature’s 65-foot tail, whose flat and wide shape resembled an oar of a ship, hit the water. The monster then stood up on his short and thick hind legs, propping him firm and stable. Lloyd noticed the monster’s bloated belly, his short front legs, and huge and round head. His water-soaked fur was dark brown and wide open mouth revealed a set of square front teeth. He stood upright, his towering height reaching 328 feet. And once again, he roared aloud.

“Bibeong!”

Fwoosh!

The tumultuous roar echoed through the lake and range dozens of times. At last, a realization hit Lloyd.

That’s not a beaver-like creature! It’s literally a beaver!

Lloyd was indeed right. King Storma, who finally emerged from his nest, didn’t just act akin to a beaver. It was his looks as well. King Storma plainly looked like a giant 328-foot beaver. What he did after he let out another cry was much like the animal as well.

Splash! King Storma leaned forward and smoothly dove into the water. And he started to swim toward the spot destroyed by Javier’s mana blast”

Okay, it’s going as planned”

Beavers manifested an infinite obsession over the dams they created out of their hands, and Lloyd planned out this operation based on that very nature. The plan was now going exactly the way Lloyd had devised, for the giant beaver made for the dam to repair it.

Good job. Just go straight. Fix the broken dam.

Lloyd internally cheered for King Storma, hoping that he would swim toward the destroyed spot. But things evolved against Lloyd’s wish as King Storma stopped dead in his tracks in the water. And he started to glance around, sniffing hard and letting out a curious cry all of a sudden.

“Bibeo-beong? Bibeong?”

Of course, his words were comprehensible to Lloyd as well. And they meant...

Something smells off...? What?

Sniff! Sniff! Sniff! King Storma’s nose sucked in the air continuously, and he could catch a faint yet strange odor hanging in the air, an odor that didn’t go well with the soil, trees, and lake. Something metallic. The smell of metal wafted out in the air, stimulating his senses.

Bibeong? Bibeo-beong?

King Storma thought to himself as he continued to sniff.

I’m sure. This thick smell of metal has to belong to humans. Only such a weak and greedy race goes around, leaving traces of this heavy, metallic smell. This only means...

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeo-beong!”

King Storma’s gaze moved toward the dam, the place he felt the vibration that woke him up a while ago. He looked at the portion of the dam.

“Bibeong!”

At last, things cleared for King Storma. He realized that the dam didn’t break due to old age or by coincidence. It was the doing of humans that smelled like metal. They must have broken them for whatever reason they had. How dare they touch his precious dam!

“Bibeo-beo-beong!”

King Storma’s large black eyes held a glint of rage. He combed the area around the lake with a burning gaze. And because of that, Lloyd gulped in nervousness.

He’s looking for us right now.

King Storma’s enraged outcry naturally translated in his head, just like when he chatted with his fantastical creatures.

He’s saying that he can smell metal. That humans are around here. That it’s the humans that woke him up and ruined his dam... Dang, he can deduce very well.

King Storma was no joke. Lloyd realized that the latter didn’t simply have the intelligence of a beast or an evil creature. He turned out to be as intelligent as Ppodong, Bangul, or Hamang, who all could reason and infer as much as the humans.

I think I need to rethink my plan.

Lloyd’s expression hardened, and he immediately collected his thoughts.

Okay, so originally, I planned to keep damaging the dam to wake King Storma up and repair the dam over and over again. I meant to repeat the same process once King Storma goes back in hibernation after finishing with the repair until the monster domino phenomenon was over. I planned to repeat the process for about a year.

Lloyd intended to semi-doom King Storma to endless work, just like the beavers Lloyd saw on TV and like Sisyphus bound to roll up the rock forever. But now, from the looks of it, Lloyd realized that he could get hurt unless he tweaked the plan.

He’s much smarter than I expected.

Lloyd had thought King Storma would be an evil creature like the Gigatitan. A beast. It never occurred to Lloyd that he would manifest the same characteristics as a fantastical creature.

So, I don’t think we can go on with our current operation as planned.

It may work this very first time, but judging by King Storma’s reasoning capacity, Lloyd would be caught two or three tries later. That was why…

I need a counterattack.

Lloyd started to rack his brain, analyzing his original plan and King Storma's nature and intelligence. He disassembled the facts as though they were pieces of a puzzle. Placing every piece on the mind floor, Lloyd allowed himself to go back to square one. He started to fit a new type of puzzle. And at last, he found the answer.

"Javier?"

Lloyd's gaze moved after finishing up the calculation, and looking straight into Javier's eyes, he said, "I need you to play the villain today."

"I'm not sure what you mean..." Javier asked with a dissatisfied look on his face.

Lloyd rolled up a corner of his lips.

"It's just as I said. I need you to be the villain. That is, to King Storma."

"To King Storma? Does that mean..." Javier's eyes glimmered for a second as he paused. "That I should kill him?"

"No. No, no! Never!" Lloyd hurriedly objected as he shook his hand hard. "You can't kill him. Come on, man. Think about it. Think what would happen if you killed him. Who's going to scare and stop the monster herds rushing into the barony because of the domino phenomenon?"

"Then..." Javier murmured, discouraged.

"King Storma's looking for someone to put the blame on."

"Excuse me? Someone to put the blame on?" asked Javier"

"Yeah, to add to that a bit, he's now searching for the trace of the culprit who ruined the dam."

"Is that the reason why he stopped approaching the dam and started to look around?"

"Yeah, can you see him sniffing now?" asked Lloyd"

“Yes.”

“He must be searching for the source of the metallic smell.”

“He must have concluded that it was a human’s doing,” concluded Javier.

“Yes, that’s it.” Lloyd grinned and continued, “So my dear brave, chic, and cynical Sir Asrahan. Will you please work on behalf of humanity today?”

“Why should I do it?”

“Because you’re handsome.”

Javier shut his mouth while Lloyd grinned viciously.

“Look around you,” said Lloyd, “Is there anyone who’s more handsome than you?”

“No one.”

“Wow. It didn’t even take a second for you to answer that.”

“It’s a clear fact,” Javier drawled”

“Right. So that makes you the representative of us.”

“What kind of logic is that...”

“To to be more specific, I want you to go where King Storma can notice you easily, and draw his attention, acting as if you’re the one who ruined his dam today.”

“You must have something in mind,” said Javier.

“Indeed. I do have something in mind. And technically speaking, you’re the one who ruined the dam anyway. Am I wrong?”

“But that was a collective effort…”

“Well, yeah, but you hit it the last,” reasoned Lloyd.

“...”

Oh, what a filthy and nasty young master you are. Javier looked daggers at Lloyd for a moment, but he soon nodded after accepting his predicament.

“Okay. I will do it. But on one condition, Master Lloyd,” said Javier.

“Do you have a favor to ask?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Nah, I refuse.”

“...”

“What? Why? What? You think I’d immediately take up your offer if you put on serious air right now?”

“Whew, no.”

“Right? Good call. Come on. Off you go. Don’t forget to fight in the shallow water, so the lake doesn’t overflow,” instructed Lloyd finally.

“Yes. Well then.”

Javier sighed, thinking about what he meant to ask for as a favor: Don’t take risks regardless of whatever it is that you plan to do. Javier lowered his body with resignation and started to walk under a bush, sneaking off for a long time until the distance between him and the others reached about 300 yards. He then got up and stood on a noticeable rock in the lake.

Swish!

A sword came out of the sheath as Javier activated the Asrahan Core Technique. He then ferociously collided with the two circles.

Boom!

A powerful mana blast ejected out of his sword, creating a loud explosive sound in the air as it cut across the wind. King Storma, which had been glancing around till then, snapped his head to immediately discover a man standing on the rock. Javier.

“Bibeong!”

King Storma clearly remembered this explosive sound. It was the booming noise he faintly heard during his sweet slumber that was interrupted. It was the noise that smashed his precious dam. The two noises were the same. King Storma was certain about it, so it was concluded that the silver-haired man standing across the lake with a sword in his hand was the culprit who ruined his beloved dam!

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

He let out a savage roar before diving into the cold water. He swam his giant body through the lake.

Swoosh!

Because King Storma had a giant body, his movement appeared slow when it wasn’t actually. The oar-like flat and wide tail whisked a huge amount of water as it moved, powerfully propelling the 328-foot body forward. It had taken only a few strokes for King Storma to arrive at the water Javier was standing.

“Bibeong!”

Splash!

He emerged from the water and instantly struck Javier down with his short and thick front leg.

Crash! His mammoth body split the rock in half. No, it was shattered to pieces. King Storma studied the smashed rock as he breathed heavily in anger. But he failed to find the body of the despicable man. Just then...

“I’m right here.”

All of a sudden, King Storma heard an icy voice about 20 yards away. A powerful shockwave charged right at him at the same time.

Kaboom! The mana blast brushed King Storma right over his head. King Storma was taken aback by the blow.

“Bibeong! (Shoot! You surprised me!)”

Surprise evolved into rage”

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

From then on, King Storma became more ferocious and wild. He let his wild nature guide him to kill this despicable human for destroying his dam. But each time he attacked, Javier easily dodged him as though he was a fruit fly. And he fired mana blasts at times, intentionally missing them. Thanks to his strategy, King Storma soon grew obsessed with Javier. Each time Javier avoided and escaped, King Storma used all his senses to focus on Javier.

“Bibeong! Bibeo-beong!”

King Storma grew more aggressive as time progressed. And so, he was completely unaware of a human devising another plan. Lloyd.

Okay. Good.

Lloyd was furtively approaching behind King Storma. And in his hand carried a sure-fire weapon that would subdue the giant beaver. It was the food that downsized fantastical creatures: the blue sunflower seed.

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Chapter 116: Taming a Fantastical Creature (2)

Okay. It's working.

Furtively and swiftly.

Lloyd moved, sliding forward at each step. He was holding the blue sunflower seed in his hand. The target was King Storma, who was going rampant in front of him.

It's worth trying to feed King Storma the blue sunflower seed.

Lloyd was certain that King Storma was a fantastical creature, and it was evidenced by his understanding of the latter's language. But Lloyd postulated that King Storma had a different nature from his own summon partners. Ppodong and Bangul were small in size on a regular day until they ate a red sunflower seed to grow gigantic for a certain period of time. Whereas King Storma was different. He was gigantic on a regular day, and the blue sunflower seed was needed to keep him small for some time.

It's plausible enough.

Or not. If his speculation turned out wrong, then he could always come up with another alternative.

I've got a lot of options in my hands. Retreat, or suppress, or kill if I'm all out of options. And it doesn't look like this one has an owner or anything.

Lloyd was actually surprised to find out that a fantastical creature he didn't summon existed in this world. But that hardly mattered. After all, what really mattered was that this monster was a fantastical creature and hinted at the chance of being tamed. That was all that mattered.

A little more.

King Storma was going wild to catch Javier. Lloyd narrowed the distance, slowly wading through the waist-deep water to get closer. Just then,

“Bibeong?”

King Storma snapped his large and round head to his side!

“...!”

Lloyd immediately ducked down, plunging deep into the water head below. The water above his head above rippled. Lloyd could see from underwater that King Storma staring at him as the latter glanced around. Just when Lloyd wondered if he was caught...

Kaboom! A mana blast came from the other side, brushing King Storma’s head. That made him focus back on Javier.

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

King Storma went wild again as he created a blaring and crashing noise. Lloyd drew a sigh of relief as he watched the back of King Storma in the water.

Woah. That beaver is more sensitive than I thought.

It was seriously dangerous a while ago. If Lloyd had been slow to react and failed to hide underwater, King Storma might have found him and attacked.

I should approach him underwater.

From then on, Lloyd started to approach King Storma by slowly crawling under the lake. He occasionally came out of the water to breathe. As he did, he direly wished for Javier’s success.

Javier! Please! Make him focus only on you!

Of course, Lloyd didn’t have telepathic powers. As such, his dire wish wasn’t shared to Javier, not an inch of it. On the other hand, Javier was thinking the following.

Master Lloyd is risking his life this time again.

Javier wished that wouldn’t be the case. But his wish wasn’t granted.

He’s always like that.

In retrospect, Master Lloyd was always like that. It was the same case when he dueled with Sir Neumann to restore order in the fiefdom, when he entered the cave of wild ants, and when he rescued the civil engineers from the hands of the dark mage Lupellan.

His words betray his actions all the time.

By now, Lloyd’s pattern was obvious to Javier. He said he despised taking risks and acted brazenly that he would never do it. But his action was...

When the most dangerous moment came, he never hesitated to be in the front.

It was just like now. He never tossed any responsibilities to someone else and took on all the risks himself. Lloyd Frontera, his young master, was the paragon of a person who proved himself through his actions.

So I suppose my role for today is this.

Javier resolved to make sure that his young master would not solely bear all the risks to himself. Whatever threat came along the way, Javier determined that he would take them. Another mana blast was emitted, and this time, it was more forceful. He continued to provoke King Storma, but he realized that he had to do more. King Storma could whip around at any moment and discover Lloyd coming in his direction. So Javier came up with a plan to up his game and draw King Storma’s attention more drastically.

“Bibeong!”

Crash!

His front leg crashed down on Javier, and he evaded swiftly, distancing away from the beaver.

“Hmm...”

He inhaled heavily. But it wasn’t to use the aura or emit a more powerful mana blast. No, not at all. After drawing in a large amount of air, he hollered at the top of his lungs.

“Bibeong!”

His mana-loaded shout rang aloud in the air, shaking up the entire lake area. It was as loud as King Storma’s roar. Could it be because of his shout? King Storma froze, and he appeared flustered. It was because what Javier had shouted a second ago meant “Mother” in King Storma's language.

“Bibeong? (But I am not your mother. And besides, I’m a male who’s been single for the past couple hundred years!)” said King Storma after stopping.

Javier then pointed at him, and he shouted once again, with greater mana this time.

“Bibeong! Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!” Javier shouted.

Of course, Javier didn’t know how to speak King Storma's language. And thus, he didn’t know what he was saying. He simply yelled. But to King Storma, this human friend made sense. “It’s going to rain tonight! Why?! I don’t have sauce on my tonkatsu!” King Storma was dismayed.

“Bibeo-beong? (Are you okay? Are you sick or anything?)”

King Storma was dismayed. This bad person who ruined his dam started to talk gibberish all of a sudden. Soon, dismay began to develop into nervousness. It was obviously the case. Imagine having your door kicked and shoved one day by a rude neighbor. Then when you open your door in anger and complain to him, he starts to talk senselessly. You realized that he was not in the right mind. The frustration would soon evolve into nervousness and fear. That was exactly what King Storma was feeling.

“Bibeong? Bibeo-beong? (Can you not fight me with the right state of mind, just like a while ago?)” King Storma sincerely asked.

To this, Javier replied, “Bibeong! Bibeo-beong! Bi-beo-beong! Bibeong! (It’s sad to hula dance with a metal chain around you! It’s good to bleed your nose! Since I am cute!)”

“Bi... beo-beong?” asked King Storma.

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong! Bibebeong! (So the king said! I tear up sometimes! I love you, braised beef!)”

“Bibeong, Bibeo-beong?”

King Storma was dismayed to the hilt. And he started to think.

Bibeong. Bibeo-beong.

This human has definitely lost it, King Storma thought to himself as he wondered if he should continue this fight. He waffled whether he should appease this man to knock some senses back into him. The more King Storma pondered hard, his whole vision and nerves focused on Javier and him only.

Good. This is working.

A mischievous smile formed on Javier’s face, and he stole a glance as he continued to holler gibberish. He saw Lloyd, who was already climbing King Storma’s tail slowly and sneakily.

Good. Very good. Just keep this up!

Lloyd cheered Javier through his gaze as he climbed King Storma’s tail with more vigor. Feeling like he had morphed into a tick, he climbed far and high until he finally arrived at King Storma’s head.

“Bibeong?”

It was only then that King Storma noticed something strange. So he snapped his head up, but it was too late.

Now!

Jump! Lloyd leaped high from the crown of his head, flinging his body in the air as he gazed downward. Lloyd saw King Storma turning his way, and their eyes met.

“Bibeong...?”

King Storma’s mouth gaped wide, and Lloyd tossed the seed right at it.

Swish! The blue sunflower seed left his hand, and as it was hurled straight, it drew a fastball trajectory. Since King Storma was dazed and frozen for a second, the seed went right into his mouth.

Gulp!

“Bibeo-beong?”

King Storma gulped the seed by reflex. And...

Boom!

He became small at about four inches tall.

Splash!

“Bibeong...?”

He instantly grew small in size. He was soon submerged in the water, which flustered King Storma. He felt chaotic.

Bibeo-beong? Bibeo-beong?

All he did was gulp something small that was tossed into his mouth, and now the whole world grew gigantic around him! Everything around his view of the lake water appeared colossal. It was a first for King Storma to see a swaying water plant bigger than him. The same went for a fish that swam by him and for a frog that hopped away in surprise. Everything looked about his size. And...

“Got you!”

“...!”

Swoosh! A grip plunged into the water to grab him in a flash. And it lifted him up.

“Bi, Bibeong!”

King Storma fiercely resisted, just like the time he chopped ten trees in one stroke and smashed a rock with his buttock. He fought and jerked and turned with power. But nothing changed. It was useless, and he couldn’t wrench himself off the grip. And the world that appeared around him... looked so vast and grand!

“Hey, have you given up now?”

“...!”

King Storma followed the arm that stretched from the grip, and it felt grand and marvelous, like the mountain range. Over it, he saw the face of a human that covered the sky. He saw the man’s dark hair dripping with water and his eyes resembling a full moon. King Storma felt stifled and hopeless. It was shocking to see an organism larger than him. And then, it hit him. It wasn’t that humans grew gigantic. He had grown... small.

“Bi, Bibeong! Bibeo-beong?! (What did you do to me?!)” yelled King Storma in a hurry.

Then King Storma noticed the man shrug.

“What did I do to you? I made you small.”

“...!”

Another shock. Was it because he confirmed that he got small? No.

Bibeong? Bibeo-beong? (Wait a minute, did I just understand what this human said? How is that even possible?)

King Storma was at a loss. This had never happened before. He searched in his memory if there was a time he understood humans. It has never happened ever since he fell into this world.

Bibeong. Bibeo-beong. Bibeong.

No one called him. No one gave birth to him. He just came to exist one day as though he was dropped from the sky. And so he lived, survived, grew, and existed. Of course, he had never met up with his kind ever before. He never thought a kind like him existed in this world, so he never imagined that he could converse with another creature. That was until he met this human who was right in front of him.

“Hey, you. You can understand me, right? Right?”

“...”

Gulp. King Storma looked at Lloyd in disbelief. Lloyd’s face lit up.

“Aha. Yes, you can. You can understand me.”

“Bi, Bibeong. Bibeo-beong.”

“Yes, I can understand you as well. So, how about we settle down and talk?” suggested Lloyd.

“Bibeong?”

“Whew. I’m beat. Let me just take a seat for now.”

“...”

“Where should I start? How about I tell you to relax a bit? I have no plans of hurting you.”

“Bibeo-beong?”

“I mean it. I won’t hurt you. I promise.”

“Bibeong...”

“You don’t trust humans?”

“Bibeo-beong. Bibeong!”

“What? You’re going to trample me if I don’t let you go now?” interpreted Lloyd.

“Bibeong!”

“Um, but that would be problematic. I’ve grown much larger than you, but I do not have you under my foot. So, how about we put an end to this fight?”

“Bibeong! Bibeo-beong!”

“You hate obeying me because I’m nothing but a human? But why?”

“Bibeo-beong!”

“So what if you’re the ruler of the lake?!”

“Bibeong!”

“Hmm.”

Lloyd was troubled.

This one’s tougher than I’d thought.

King Storma was resisting very hard to escape out of Lloyd’s grip. He turned out to be more stubborn and tenacious than Lloyd pegged him to be. And it appeared that he was hostile to humans. Minus the capacity to converse, King Storma was as good as an untamed wild animal.

He’s completely different from Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang.

Lloyd wondered if the difference was because King Storma wasn’t summoned by himself. Should he opt for a rougher method to tame this

creature? Lloyd pondered on it but immediately shook his head.

He might close himself up to me if I do that, and that's going to be more problematic.

Lloyd had risked himself and succeeded in feeding the blue sunflower seed to King Storma. The seed would last only 24 hours, so sooner or later, he would grow gigantic again to become a 328-foot beaver. Lloyd needed to either make him come around or tame him before the hour was up.

The best result is to persuade him and have him protect this place of his own volition. What should I do?

Lloyd racked his brain, thinking very hard. Just then, an idea came to him.

Wait a minute. Will he loosen up if I introduce him to other fantastical creatures?

Lloyd slightly opened his inner pocket at the brilliant possibility.

"Hey, Ppodong. Bangul. Hamang?"

"Pupung! Ppodong!"

"Ba, Bangul!"

"Hamamang!"

They answered from his inner pocket, which was filled with water like a tub. The corners of Lloyd's mouth slowly crept up.

"We have a new friend. Would you like to meet him?"

"Ppo! Bang! Ha!"

Their response and reaction were immediate. Ppodong got out of the pocket with Hamang on his back, climbing up to Lloyd's shoulder. They looked at King Storma, who was still in Lloyd's grip.

“Ppodong?”

“Hamang?”

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong! Arggggggh!!”

King Storma revealed his sharp front teeth as he looked at them both. But what came next...

“Bangul?”

Bangul slithered up to Lloyd’s shoulder later than the others after fixing her soaked ribbon and getting the water out of her bell. She then revealed herself, her face glowing in the water. And her round and dark eyes glimmered as she gazed at this “new friend” Lloyd mentioned.

“Bba-bangul?”

Her calling drew King Storma’s attention.

“Bibeo-beong?”

King Storma growled just as he did a while ago, and his gaze moved toward Lloyd’s shoulder. But there, he saw Bangul, who was perched on the human shoulder, and his eyes locked with her glimmering eyes. Just then, the scowl on King Storma’s face disappeared, and he felt dazed.

“Bi... Beong?”

That day, King Storma fell in love for the first time.

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Chapter 117: How to Reverse the Domino (1)

“What? I’m your owner now?” asked Lloyd.

“Bibeong!”

“Don’t you think it’s a bit too drastic a change of attitude?”

“Bibeo-beong. Bibeong.”

“Come on, this couldn’t have been your plan in the first place. And are you sure you want me to call you Bibeong? Really?”

“Bibeong!”

“Hmm.”

King Storma, no, Bibeong nodded his chubby head. Lloyd stroked his jaw as he stared at Bibeong with doubt-filled eyes.

“You. Something’s off about you,” Lloyd said.

“Bibeong?”

“You changed so drastically. Just a while ago, you growled as though you were trying to start a fight with all of us here.”

“Bibeo-beong?”

“Come on. I was almost worried that you’d bite my hands.”

“Bibeong?”

“Don’t play innocent. That was just a minute ago.”

“Bi, Bibeong.”

“Don’t recall, eh?”

“Bibeong.”

“Ha, you were just testing my sincerity?”

“Bi-Bibeobeong.”

“Hmm...”

King Storma, no, Bibeong was sitting on Lloyd’s palm. Lloyd narrowed his eyes as he looked at him.

Something’s going on with him.

Lloyd recalled the event a while ago. Bibeong was violent, to say the least. Even though Lloyd succeeded in making him small with the blue sunflower seed, the creature couldn’t be negotiated with or persuaded. Continuing the conversation alone proved to be difficult because he was extremely hostile to humans.

He was an absolute wild animal.

The fact that the two spoke the same language was no use because Bibeong didn’t open his heart to Lloyd. Nothing could persuade him, so Lloyd was troubled. That was why he racked his brain to come up with the idea of introducing Bibeong to Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang. Lloyd did so in the hopes that this encounter may soften Bibeong’s attitude even a little. But to Lloyd’s surprise, the moment he showed Bibeong his friends, Bibeong changed his attitude by 180 degrees. His transformation took place at lightning speed.

Something’s definitely going on with him here.

The beaver had been wild, throwing such a terrible tantrum. There was definitely something that calmed him down.

I might be able to manipulate him easily if I find out what that is.

Lloyd’s eyes narrowed to slits, and he studied Bibeong standing on his palm. His eyes scrutinized Bibeong’s motion, expression, and gaze. He

scanned and analyzed every single thing without anything amiss. Then, Lloyd faintly saw something.

The angle of his standing posture. 45 degrees from Bangul's perspective. He's standing at an angle that would make his belly look the slimmest. And look! He keeps glancing over at Bangul.

Lloyd was getting close.

Wait a minute. Is he...?

A corner of Lloyd's lips curved upward.

"Hey, you," called Lloyd.

"Bibeong?"

"You have a crush, don't you?"

"Bi, Bibeong?"

"And I think I know who that is."

"Bibeo-beong. Bibeong?"

Bibeong's expression shook visibly. The smile on Lloyd's face deepened.

"Oh, oh! Her head is round while her body is chubby. Her tail is rattling-"

"Bibeo-beong! Bibeong! Bibeo-beo-beong!"

"Never ever? You know nothing of it? Are you sure?"

"Bibeong!"

Bibeong hurriedly nodded his head. Once again, the corners of Lloyd's mouth went further up.

Got you. Looks like you are smitten with Bangul. But what about Bangul?

Lloyd quickly observed Bangul. She was simply looking at Bibeong as she tilted his head to the side. There was only curiosity in her eyes. Nothing more than that.

Oh, the sorrow of unrequited love.

Lloyd welcomed Bibeong to the single's club. With a beaming grin on his face, he spoke.

"Well, okay. If you say so."

"Bibeong!"

"Yes, good. Anyway, so I'm your owner now, eh?"

"Bibeo-beong."

"You made the right call. But I have a question for you."

"Bibeong?"

"Who summoned you?"

Lloyd was sincerely curious about who had summoned Bibeong and why he was living here all alone by himself without an owner.

This could mean that I might not be the only one who can summon fantastical creatures.

This was an important matter because this could mean that someone might enjoy the benefits of the RP system. Lloyd was intrigued by who it was that got Bibeong into this world. And so, Lloyd was probably relieved when he heard Bibeong's response.

"Bibeo,beong! Bibeong! Bibeong! Bibeong."

"What? No one summoned you here?"

"Bibeong!"

Bibeong nodded and continued to speak.

“Bibeong. Bibeong. Bibeo-beong.”

“Hmm, so to sum it up, you just came to be in this world, and no one was around you. And you’ve never met a fantastical creature like you?”

“Bibeong!”

“For over 500 years...?” asked Lloyd.

“Bibeong!”

“Hmm.”

It appeared Bibeong was a rare case where a fantastical creature was born into this world by natural occurrence. Lloyd made that conclusion and was putting the thought behind him when Bibeong asked him a question in a concerned voice.

“Bibebeong? Bibeong?”

“What’s that? Are you asking if he’s all right?”

“Bibeong!”

Bibeong was pointing at one side with a nervous expression on his face. The person he was pointing at was...

“His name is Javier Asrahan. What about him?”

“Bibeong, Bibeo-beobeong. Bibeong!”

“Haha! He started to talk senselessly out of the blue?”

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

“His gibberish was on another level, eh? But you don’t have to worry about whether he has lost it.”

“Bibeong!”

“Really, he’s fine. He just loses it sometimes.”

“Bibeo-beong?”

“Actually, everyone called him a genius when he was young. But he fell from a persimmon tree when he was seven, and then...” Lloyd paused with a sad expression on his face.

“Master Lloyd, I can hear everything.”

“...”

“I did not know,” continued Javier, “that you were well-versed in spreading false rumors and propaganda.”

“Ehem. Did you see that? He’s normal usually, but he just, you know, only sometimes. Please understand him with a big heart,” persuaded Lloyd.

“Bibeong!”

Bibeong nodded as he beamed while Javier grimaced slightly. Lloyd chuckled at them.

Anyway, mission accomplished.

The mission was to wake King Stoma, the ruler of Lake Kapua, and force him to mark his territory and stop the monster domino phenomenon. It was accomplished. But Lloyd managed to achieve more than waking him up. He succeeded in being Bibeong’s master, and Bibeong was now at his disposal.

Looks like I over-accomplished my mission.

Of course, establishing the pet-master relationship wasn’t the end of it. Moreover, the downside and upside for Bibeong were that he was way too big.

He’s completely opposite to other creatures like Ppodong.

Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang were usually small. Just the perfect size to put them in his inner pocket. Lloyd only needed to increase their size with the red sunflower seed whenever he wanted. But Bibeong was different. He was 328 feet tall on a normal day. Lloyd could downsize Bibeong if he needed to put Bibeong in his pocket. But there was a 24-hour limit.

It means that I have a limit to taking him around and using him.

So, the question was whether Lloyd should use Bibeong as he had intended in the first place, which involved leaving Bibeong free in Lake Kapua to act as a deterrent to the monster invasion. And if the rare need to use him arose, Lloyd would take him. He was contemplating the matter when he was interrupted.

“Master Lloyd.”

It was Javier who called. When Lloyd turned, he found Javier pointing beyond the lake.

“It looks like our recon team is coming this way,” said Javier.

“What? Which one?” asked Lloyd.

“The team we’d dispatched beyond the eastern range the other time.”

“Oh, them.”

Lloyd peered at the area Javier was pointing at across the lake. A group of men dressed in civil engineer uniforms appeared in view. Though they were far, Lloyd could notice them somewhat. It was the patrol team Lloyd had dispatched to the orc tribe right after they blocked the herd of Mastodons.

“Let’s go.”

It looked like they were returning after running a recon. Lloyd led everyone to the other side through the dam in the lake. The team met and were delighted to see Lloyd and the rest.

“Master Lloyd. I didn’t know I would bump into you here.”

“Indeed. Is everyone safe?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, not a single one of us was hurt, thankfully.”

The leader of the recon team was the soldier who had once hurt his back during the seokbinggo construction in the orc village.

“That’s a relief. What about the orc village?” asked Lloyd. “How are they?”

“Um, the thing is...” He paused, his expression looking somewhat grim. “They are fighting very hard.”

“Fighting? Could it be against the rushing monsters?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Woah.” Lloyd let out a sigh.

He knew very well that the orc tribe was made up of ferocious warriors. Even so, it surprised him that they were facing the fight head-on without taking refuge.

The damage must be immense.

The monster domino phenomenon was no joke. Blocking one wave of monsters didn’t mean it was the end. More and more kinds of monsters came rushing like an unending wave. One or two defenses didn’t cut it. Like how a sharp rock got smoothened by continuous waves, even the most powerful capabilities died down eventually. They would get tired until they finally collapsed. That was what was truly scary about this event.

That is the reason why I tried to create a biological wall using Bibeong.

And yet, here were the orcs taking the full brunt of the monsters without retreating. Lloyd was astonished by their bravery and boldness. At the same time, he thought that he should save them.

They are my steadfast ally.

His decision, however, wasn’t a moral one. It was extremely practical. These orc friends were useful, so he didn’t want to lose the orc tribe so easily.

What should I do?

He stopped and started to think about an effective way to support the orcs while minimizing any damage and maximizing the benefits on his part. The status quo was immediately put under review, and so were his current capabilities and resources. Timing and opportunity. Benefits and losses. Processes and results. He pieced together all these elements as though he was building them up. He placed and elevated them to draw out a full picture at last.

“Bibeong,” called Lloyd.

“Bibeong?”

“Do you think you can carry all of us if you grow big again?”

“Bibeo-beong?”

“We’re thinking of heading east to the wilderness at the foot of the mountain range. Do you think you can do that?”

“Bibeong? Bibeo-beong?”

Bibeong’s face grew agitated. He had spent almost his entire life around this lake area, so the suggestion to leave this lake and make for the wilderness was off-putting even though it was coming from Lloyd, his new master. But something he heard afterwards changed his stance right away.

“If you grant my request, someone is going to be very, very happy.”

Lloyd’s sweet voice pierced into Bibeong’s ears. To add to his voice, Lloyd wriggled his eyes toward Bangul.

“Bibeong...?”

Bibeong gulped dryly as he wondered if that was true. He asked himself whether Bangul would truly be happy if he carried everyone to the foot of the mountain range in the east. Lloyd spoke again, and this time, his voice grew subtler.

“Now, think about it. Just imagine in your head how happy she will be,” Lloyd cooed. “She is faithfully serving me at my side right now. What do you think will happen if she sees you obedient to my words? Don’t you think she will feel the camaraderie and assurance of serving the same owner?”

“Bi, Bibeong?”

“What I am saying is that her gaze toward you may change,” Lloyd cajoled.

“...”

“How’s that?”

The question was like a poisonous apple that looked so glossy and scrumptious on the outside. At last, Bibeong gave in and nodded hard at Lloyd.

“Bi, Bibeong! Bibeo-beong!”

“I knew you could do it! Wow, you are awesome. I’m sure she thinks so, too.”

“Bibeong!”

Bibeong held up his tiny front leg. And he stole a glance at Bangul as he took the red sunflower seed Lloyd was giving him. And he moved about 100 yards away from the rest of them and ate it up.

Crunch. Gulp.

The change was immediate.

Boom! The world around him grew small again as he went back to his original size.

“Bibeong! Bibeo-beong!”

Bibeong roared ferociously after he became 328-feet in size. He lowered his body to the ground, motioning at Lloyd to hop on. Getting onboard was a smooth experience. Lloyd, Javier, 20 men of the patrol team, and 500 lancers of the White Cavalry hopped on Bibeong’s back, which still had a lot of space as it was that vast and wide.

“Okay, let’s go! To the east!”

“Bibeong! (Hold tight!)”

Bibeong bellowed as he leaped, and just like that, he left Lake Kapua, his home. He made for the east, and it took only one step for him to cross the valley. And several steps later, he was already at the peak. Some panting and huffing later, the range was already crossed behind him. After just six hours of travel, Bibeong crossed the eastern range.

“Great. Keeping moving east!” Lloyd urged.

“Bibeong!”

Lloyd was on top of Bibeong’s head, acting as a human navigation machine. And at last, a familiar terrain came into his view. It was the path he had taken to look for the cave of the dark magician. And soon, more familiar sights appeared. The limestone quarry site where Javier first used the mana blast. The yellow and deserted wilderness beyond it. And the massive sandstorm forming over there.

That’s where the Sand and Steel Tribe is.

Lloyd’s eyes narrowed as he observed the sand dust. It was certainly happening at the place he remembered to be where the orc tribe was at. He focused on hearing, and he picked up several shouts and roars coming in the distance.

“Bibeong, I want you to listen to me carefully now!” Lloyd instantly hurried.

“Bibeong!”

“Let us get off over there first. And once we’re all down, I want you to rush toward the sandstorm.”

“Bibeo-beong?”

“Yes, charge right at it. And you’ll see orcs and monsters in the storm,” Lloyd said.

“Bibeong? Bibeo-beong?”

“No, the orcs aren’t your enemies.BLeave them alone. But thrash against the monsters,” Lloyd quickly instructed.

“Bibeong?”

“Yes, as ferocious and marvelous as you can. To the point that these monsters will spread rumors to the others as they run back to the east in terror. Do you think you can do it? If you could do it very well...” Lloyd paused. And he lowered his voice to make sure that it sounded suggestive. “I am sure she will love it.”

“Bibeong!”

“She” was the magic word for Bibeong, for he nodded right away. After everyone got down, Bibeong hurtled toward the Sand and Steel tribe village, hoping that Bangul would notice how cool he was and fall in love with him. For the first time ever in his life, Bibeong burned with zealous passion.

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong! (Move orcs!)”

He rushed into the sand storm as he roared and brushed past the orc warriors, who froze at his appearance. Then, Bibeong spotted his enemy amid the thick sandstorm.

“Grrr?”

The 168-foot evil creature widened its eyes at the appearance of Bibeong. Its mouth was elongated like an alligator, and its teeth stuck out irregularly. And its skin was so thick like armor that even the horns could not penetrate it. The claws were specialized to tear the stomach of its game. It was the Megalania, the evil creature known for being the most violent creature in the wilderness. But what was Megalania to Bibeong? He didn’t give a hoot. Right now, everything that stood in his way was to be sacrificed at the altar of love.

“Bibeo-beong!”

Boooom! With a power-charged roar, Bibeong threw a 3,000-ton first-love jab at Megalania’s face.

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Chapter 118: How to Reverse the Domino (2)

“Bibeo-beong!”

Boooom! Bibeong’s savage roar boomed across the land. But his blow was louder than his roar, as it sounded like a peal of thunder. The result of his blow was destructive.

“Gargh....?”

Megalania’s head was hurled to the side, more than ten of its teeth flinging away in the air. It was only natural. Bibeong boasted a towering height of 328 feet. Even without the tail, he was 262 feet. He had a chubby physique compared to his height, which made him weigh over 3,000 tons. The punch contained every fiber of his massive weight. But there was something else more to his mighty punch than his weight. It was Bangul, his first love. She was watching him from behind. And so, Bibeong had harnessed every bit of energy he could scrape up in that punch.

“Bibeong! Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

Wham! Thwack! Crash!

Left foot, right foot, left foot. The Megalania was sentenced to three 3,000-ton punches, each blow sending the monster up in the air like an ankle sock swirling in a tornado.

“Gaaarrrr!!”

A scream escaped out of its mouth. The counterattack was unthinkable because its body was a mere 164 feet. And its body was 1/4 the size of Bibeong, weighing only 700 tons.

“Bibeong!”

Bam! Bibeong wielded his front arm once again.

“Gargh!!”

Five punches were thrown in a row, but they were enough to make Megalania severely groggy. And Bibeong threw one more final blow.

“Bibeo-beong!”

Crack!

He bit the back of Megalania with his large teeth. Then he hurled it high and shook and let it go.

Whoosh! The 164-foot height and 700-ton Megalania was catapulted high in the air, flying about 400 yards. And it fell.

Boom! Crash! After being sent away for a couple of yards in the air, it hit the ground, leaving a large hole. That alone compromised Megalania’s combat power”

“Grrrr.... Garggh....”

The megalania, which was beaten to a pulp, closely rose from the ground. It was lucky that it wasn’t dead. Its whole body was shaky and trembling. Six more Megalanias were around the injured one. But none of them dared to extract their fangs as the one thrown to the ground was their leader.

“Garrrr!! Garggh!”

The horribly injured Megalania turned around and began to run toward the east, its tail lowered to the ground. As the leader left, the others followed suit.

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

Bibeong let out a roar of triumph, and he stole a glance to the west where Lloyd and the others were. To be exact, there was Bangul, who was perched on Lloyd’s shoulder.

Bibeong, Bibeo-beobeong...

Bibeong direly wished that she saw the awesome feat he had achieved. He feigned some coughs, which brought Lloyd to smile wryly.

My, that beaver is too obvious.

Lloyd noticed how clumsy Bibeong was and thought that there was a reason why he was single. But that side of him appealed to Lloyd, who felt a sense of camaraderie from Bibeong.

“Bangul?” called Lloyd.

“Bangul!”

“I have a favor to ask you. Could you jiggle your bell once for Bibeong?” asked Lloyd.

“Bba-bangul?”

“You know, just to boost his spirit.”

“Bangul!”

Bangul nodded her round head up and down. Bangul, too, didn’t dislike Bibeong. But her feelings were that of friendship and nothing else.

“Bangul! Bba-bangul! (Good job, my new friend!)”

Bangul slightly lifted her tail up and jiggled. The vivid noise rang aloud, instantly bringing a pinkish smile to Bibeong, who was breathing heavily from the hard punches.

Hmm. This is just perfect”

Now that the appropriate reward had been given, it was time for Lloyd to do his job.

“Everybody, please wait up here for a while.”

Lloyd asked his delegation to stand by and made for the east alone, crossing the calming sand storm. He saw hundreds of orc warriors standing as they chatted. He then raised his voice toward the biggest orc warrior among them.

“Long time no see, chief!”

“Eh? Oink?”

The biggest warrior was Akush, the chief of the Sand and Steel tribe. He perked up his ears. Actually, he was in a state of considerable dismay as astonishing events had taken place in series.

What is this situation, oink?

Monsters had been invading the village in series lately, and yet, Akush had been fighting indomitably against them. The same went for today. There was a violent and savage herd of Megalania, and he was fighting against six of them. He let out a roar in the frontline and threw a javelin to make sure that his warriors would not lose courage and retreat. But all of a sudden, something hurtled toward his way with impressive force and stomped by. And in one powerful blow, the intruder threw a hard punch against the Megalania and bit it up to send it flying away beyond the village territory.

What in the world is that, oink?!

Beating the daylights out of the Megalania was hard enough. And yet, the intruder hurled it away in the distance. This intruder was a giant monster that resembled a beaver. And now... he was hearing a familiar voice from behind.

This voice seems to be Lloyd, an honorable warrior of my tribe but a weak human, oink.

To Akush, Lloyd was kind but weak. That was how Akush remembered Lloyd. He turned around, thinking about that recollection, and found Lloyd walking over to him”

“Hoho, oink?”

A friend. A smile naturally formed on Akush’s face. Chief Akush smiled as he revealed his large fangs. Worm-like veins popped on his huge pecs.

“What brings you here, my friend? It’s dangerous here today. It is dangerous, especially to a weak friend like you, so you better go back home, oink,” advised Akush.

“Dangerous? Is it because of the monsters?” asked Lloyd”

“Yes, oink!”

A smile vanished from Akush’s face. He held up his ax and pointed toward the east, where Bibeong was standing.

“Countless monsters are invading these days. Today, Megalanias have come. But right now, a worse one has appeared. It is very dangerous, oink.”

“Oh,” Lloyd replied, “are you talking about that one?”

“Yes, oink.”

“Then, you have nothing to worry about. I am his owner,” said Lloyd”

“What, oink...?”

“I mean it. His name is Bibeong.”

“...”

Lloyd masters over the monster that defeated Megalanias with one punch? What is he? Akush was slightly overwhelmed by his presence.

Feeling such, Akush asked, “So? What brings you here, my friend? Have you come here to fight with us, oink?”

“Well, something like that.”

Catching up can happen later. Right now, it was time for business.

“I am sure it was a tough ride for the last few days. The locusts, Mastodons, and the Megalania. It was one heck of a ride, wasn’t it?”

“Hmph! It was fine. Perfect days for working out, oink!”

“Yes, yes,” agreed Lloyd, “I am sure they were perfect. But do you happen to know the reason why these incidents occurred?”

“No, oink!”

“And so I am here,” said Lloyd, “to give you the cause and solution.”

Lloyd grinned. From now on, it was time to stop the monster domino phenomenon and lay a massive counterattack to the sultan kingdom responsible for this mess.

***

The counterattack operation took place in a breeze. Lloyd walked Akush through in great detail the unforgivable actions of the sultan's kingdom. For obvious reasons, Akush blew a fuse. But not just him. Every member of the orc warrior was enraged, and so they readily participated in the operation.

“The operation is simple. From now on, for the next few days, we are going to lay an indiscriminate attack on every monster milling around this area. Of course, Bibeong will be at the center of the offense.”

The orc warriors were assigned to threaten the monsters aghast by Bibeong’s attack. They were responsible for rounding up the monsters to the east.

“However,” Lloyd explained, “you must keep something in mind. Monsters can get injured. But don’t kill them. Let them stay alive as they run away.”

“Why, oink?”

“So that they will spread rumors among the surviving ones. Then--”

“Then what? Oink,” hurried Akush.

“The monsters charging from the east to this place will reverse their path. Just like when they came here. They will make way for the east, and thus, turn the direction of the domino.”

“Woah, oink!!”

“Do you get what I am saying?” asked Lloyd.

“No, it’s complicated, oink!”

“Well, anyway, what we do will cause serious trouble to the sultan kingdom’s western border.”

“I like that. Let us get right to it, oink!”

And thus began the operation. It started immediately. And no one felt a pang of guilt in doing so. The western border of the sultan kingdom that was to be affected by the monsters was thankfully unpopulated.

Its western border is bare. No fiefdoms or villages. Just the forces that defend the border.

So there would be zero innocent casualties by Lloyd’s counterattack. Plus, since the forces on the border are protected by the fortress, no one would really get hurt.

But they’ll be super busy taking care of the herds of monsters. The senior leadership will also learn something from it.

It was that the sultan kingdom wasn’t the only one that could stir the monster domino. The kingdom could do it as well. So, the act of enabling the monster domino phenomenon could be counterattacked and retaliated against. Lloyd wanted to plant that message to the leaders in the sultan kingdom.

That way, they’ll never dare to try to do this tomfoolery again.

The principle was similar to nuclear deterrence. If a country owned a nuclear weapon, it was harder for another country to use it. The message was the same here: You're not the only one with the weapon. Sending the message was the objective of this operation on top of the revenge"

"So now, let's get started."

There was no reason to waffle. The mission was initiated right away, and Bibeong, the orc warriors, Javier, and the White Cavalry performed extraordinary feats. They scavenged every corner of the wilderness in a frenzy, rushing to anywhere they could find a strand of monster hair. They beat, strangled, bent, threw, roared, and threatened. Every monster that got the taste of their reckoning fled to the east in fright. The operation lasted for six days. By that time, not a single monster was to be found in the area because they spread the rumor among themselves and rushed to the other end. In other words, their mission succeeded.

"Whew, since we're on the topic anyway..." Lloyd started.

This conversation took place after the reverse domino operation had succeeded. Lloyd and Akush were at the center of the orc village, which was almost in ruins by the incessant invasions of monsters.

"I am quite wary of saying this, but how about moving the tribe's village to somewhere else?" suggested Lloyd.

"Move the orc village? Oink?"

"Yes," replied Lloyd.

Tossing the sandburs branch into the crackling bonfire in front of him, Lloyd spoke.

"Certainly," he said, "I understand this land is precious to you as you have lived here for generations. But think about it. As this incident has revealed to us, the village has little defense because it sits in an open area."

"But we are strong, oink," rebutted Akush.

“I am aware. But I am bringing this subject up because you will be stronger once you move your village,” reasoned Lloyd.

“What? We will be stronger, oink?”

“Yes.”

“How so, oink?”

“Um, I’ve actually wanted to tell you this for a long time. I know I built a seokbinggo for you earlier, but this wilderness suffers from a severe food shortage. So, it is very unfortunate. This is not a great place to build muscle from a nutritional standpoint,” said Lloyd.

“What...? Muscle, oink?”

At the word “muscle,” Akush’s eyes flew wide open. The same thing happened to the other orc warriors that sat in groups near the fire. Lloyd noticed that his plan was working. Smothering the grin, he spoke up.

“You must rest and eat well. Those two are just as important as working out. This, however, is something you know very well, correct?” Lloyd said as he looked at Akush.

“Yes, yes, oink.”

“And so, my heart aches to be honest. It aches because of your tragic reality, where you and your men fail to enlarge your muscles by the shackles of your tradition.”

“Enlarge muscles, oink?”

“Yes,” replied Lloyd.

“H-how do I do that, oink?”

“It’s actually not that difficult. Um, I normally don’t tell this to others. But are you interested in hearing it?”

“Tell us now! Oink!”

“Okay, good. Look over there.”

Lloyd held out his hand, which pointed to the eastern range that spanned like a folding screen.

“Deer with luscious and rich hair run about the grass, and fat wild boars enjoy the flowery gardens. Overhead, mountain pigeons and pheasants flutter their wings. Just imagine it. The breast of the mountain pigeons that fly mightily. Imagine the juiciness of the breasts of those pheasants which pulse so fiercely.”

“Y-yummy, oink.”

“Yes, that is right. But that’s not all. The creek is so rich that it’s half filled with water, and the other half is fish. Since it’s the best of the best water, lobsters inhabit there. Imagine steaming a lobster compact with protein. Where do you think it’ll go when you eat it?”

“To my m-muscles, oink?!”

“Truly, you are the chief. You know it very well,” complimented Lloyd”

“Then, do you suggest that we move to the eastern range, oink?”

“Of course. What’s more, technically speaking, you are not breaking tradition by doing so,” Lloyd reasoned”

“How so, oink?”

The word “tradition” made Akush flinch in guilt. Lloyd then spoke up to relieve him of such a burden.

“Just think about it,” cajoled Lloyd, “your ancestors were muscular orcs, weren’t they?”

“Of course, yes, oink!”

“What do you think they would want their children to be?” suggested Lloyd.

“Muscular! So much so that it’s going to burst, oink!”

“That’s exactly what I mean. I knew you would understand. You are so wise even when I don’t say anything aloud.”

“Are you saying that my ancestors would want us to eat well and enjoy bulky muscles, oink?”

Just then, a glint of hesitation appeared in Akush’s eyes. He, too, was aware that the eastern range held an abundance of games. That was why he occasionally sent his warriors to the range. But still, the efficiency of settling down in the lush woods could not be compared to that of dispatching some men there. Right now, it took them several days just to get there.

“B-but, I cannot leave the land of my ancestors... Oink...”

“Your ancestors will be pleased as well,” cooed Lloyd.

“If we have bulky muscles, oink”?

“Of course.”

Lloyd’s whisper sounded sweet and provoking to Akush’s ears, which were muscular as well. Lloyd’s tempting words pierced deep into the hearts of orc warriors around him. And at last, a decision was reached.

“Good! From today on, our land is the eastern range. Do lead us, oink!”

And just like that, the Sand and Steel tribe moved to the eastern range. This move was exactly what Lloyd wanted.

Bibeong conquers Lake Kapua. And now, the orc tribe will settle in the eastern range. Two great walls will defend my fiefdom from now on.

And should something happen to the fiefdom, Lloyd could now ask for help from the orc tribe.

So I can now say goodbye to this sickening physical threat. It's over.

Lloyd was certain it was over. When the financial crisis was overcome, next came the physical threat that imperiled his fiefdom. That dangerous element was, at last, overcome. Lloyd felt light and weightless as he went back to the barony.

One last thing remains right now.

Lloyd thought to himself. It was something he desperately wanted to take care of. Debt clearance. And now, the time had come for him to pay the entire debt with the money he'd earned from the royal capital.

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Chapter 119: Joyful Day (1)

Lloyd opened his eyes. He blinked several times. The scene around him was unfamiliar. He wasn't in the barony manor where the shabby village came into view through the bedroom window or where the magnificent mountain range appeared when Lloyd turned east. He was not in the bedroom in the barony he had gotten used to for the past year and a half.

The royal tomb?

The blue sky and green grass. Hills that were up to dozens of feet tall stood intermittently. The place looked like the royal tomb in Gyeongju that he once went to and stayed in his memory afterward.

"Ha..."

Lloyd couldn't make sense of this situation. He wondered why his eye level was low. It was as though he was back to when he was a 12-year-old boy.

Am I dreaming...?

With that though, Lloyd stared at his two hands. They were small, soft, and smooth. He didn't have a single callus from shoveling nor a scar on the back of his hand from his time in the military. It wasn't there. He blankly wiggled his hands. They certainly belonged to a young boy.

Wait, I think I'm...

It was strange. He was certain that he had come back to the barony late the previous night and collapsed on the bed in sheer exhaustion. He fell asleep, telling himself that he would clear every penny of the debt the next morning.

So what's this...

Just when he was trying to process the dismaying situation, he heard someone speak to him.

“Suho,” the voice called, “did you wait for long?”

The voice coming from behind him was familiar. It was a slightly rough and cold voice. The owner of the voice had a dialect and accent he couldn’t fix even after his wife’s nagging. But there was an intermittent warmth that came out amid his usual roughness.

“Father...?”

Lloyd wheeled around in surprise as he called and saw a shadow that stood tall, covering the sun. His father then bent forward to meet his eyes and grinned.

“My, look at my boy. Did something happen? You’re calling me ‘father’ not ‘dad’.”

“Um, I...” Lloyd trailed off.

“My boy is all grown up now. Here you go. Eat this.”

“...”

Lloyd looked at the object his father held out. It was a bottle of medicine that helped digestion and a pack of bubble gum.

Is it really that day?

A memory struck him just then. Lloyd’s father was a busy man, so he didn’t spend much time with him. They never took a trip together or did anything like that. His only memory of them was this one when he turned 12 years old. They took a father-son trip to Gyeongju. Similar to today, the weather had been great. The clear blue sky, green royal tomb, and white clouds. Lloyd had walked quite a lot, holding Father’s hand. But he got carsick because he forgot to plaster an anti-nausea patch.

“What is it? Is something wrong?” His father asked. “Do you want me to open it for you?”

“...”

“Here you go. Just drink up and burp. That would do it. Come on.”

“...”

Lloyd took the bottle. Something hot surged from his heart, and he chugged the medicine, swallowing the hot lump as well.

“Here, take this one as well.”

“...”

Before Lloyd knew it, his father had opened a pack of gum already, and he held out one to him. It was bubble gum. His favorite kind.

“...”

Lloyd was confused as to why he was having this dream. In sheer disbelief, he stared at his father, who looked back at him in concern.

“Are you all right? Can’t burp, eh?”

“N-no, it’s not that. The thing is...”

Lloyd was at a loss for words. The words he wanted to say kept coming up deep within, but he couldn’t make them come out of his mouth because of the heavy feeling in his heart.

“I’m fine,” Lloyd finally managed.

Father grinned and said, “Are you sure?”

“Yes.”

Since Lloyd didn’t know what else to say, he held out his hand and grabbed Father’s large hand. And the two walked, just like the day he turned 12.

“...”

Things started to make sense a little. This was definitely a dream, though it was too real. But it was a dream nonetheless, and Lloyd wondered when he would wake up. He wondered how much time he had to see his Father's face. Lloyd was walking with that thought in his head when his Father spoke.

"But, Suho," Father called.

Lloyd felt that his stomach was fine now. Is Father still worried? Lloyd thought to himself. He looked up and found his father's eyes trembling with tears welling up in the corners. And in a voice mixed with a sigh, his father spoke.

"Son, you did good. You worked so hard."

"What...?"

This line wasn't in Lloyd's memory. This conversation didn't take place when he was 12 years old. Feeling a bit dazed, Lloyd saw his father's nose grow red.

"I'm sorry. It's been really hard, right? It's not your fault. You just happened to have a poor and incompetent father."

"..."

"But that's why I'm proud of you all the more."

"That's..." Lloyd couldn't finish words.

"I'm proud of you, my son."

Tap. Tap.

"..."

Lloyd closed and opened his eyes. A familiar room showed up. It was the bedroom he had gotten used to for the last year and a half.

“Whew...”

It was morning. And it was a dream. Lloyd rose up from his bed and called the maids just like he always did. After washing his face with the water a maid got for him, he put on his clothes and had breakfast. He woke Javier up and started his day by calling the administrator.

“Are Shiloh and Meatloaf back?” asked Lloyd.

“Oh, yes, Master Lloyd. They are said to have returned two days ago,” the administrator said.

“Goodness, those two fellows know when danger is near.”

The moment the barony was under a monster invasion, the two loan sharks fled away. A snort had escaped when Lloyd heard they were back.

“Great. Please call them here,” Lloyd requested.

“Yes. Is there anything that you wish to tell them?”

“No, that won’t be necessary. Just call them, please,” Lloyd said. But a second later, he added with a grin, “Oh, you know what? Please tell them the time has come to happily end this relationship of ours.”

“Yes, I will tell them that.”

“All right. Thank you.”

The administrator left, and the wait began. Lloyd spent half of the day thinking as he waited for Shiloh and Meatloaf to arrive. To be honest, Lloyd was disturbed in a lot of ways.

Is it because I’m paying off my debt today? Or is it because of the dream I had earlier this morning?

Lloyd couldn’t decide which one it was. The sense of dismay inside of him continued to linger even when the two loan sharks arrived.

“Ahaha. Long time no see, young master.”

“My, you are looking very good today.”

Shiloh and Meatloaf playfully joked at Lloyd as they handed him a bottle of wine. Lloyd once couldn’t stand the sight of the two, who looked as if they would follow him to the depths of hell to demand repayment. But not anymore. Now, he wondered if he grew fond of them over time. Smothering the wry smile forming on his face, he spoke.

“Thank you for coming all the way here. I hope you both have been well.”

“Haha, we almost died.”

“The locust swarm. Whew.”

“I am very relieved that you are safe and can receive all the remaining debt from me today.”

Shiloh and Meatloaf, who were joking with smiles on their faces, suddenly grew serious, and their smiles vanished. They cocked their heads to the side in utter disbelief.

“What do you mean that we can receive all the remaining debt from you?” asked Shiloh”

“Could you mean-”

“Yes, that is right,” Lloyd interrupted. “The time has come to happily end our old relationship. I am sure you have heard this already from my messenger.”

“...”

The two loan sharks were silent.

“I guess you should check the money first. Please follow me. Over here,” Lloyd said as he grinned and rose from his seat.

At the thought of clearing the debt, Lloyd's knees trembled a little.

***

Paying off the debt was simple. It was so simple that it felt meaningless and vain. Lloyd simply handed the check he had received from the queen. Meatloaf and Shiloh verified the amount and the queen's signature written on the check, and they went over the contract. They then wrote a document confirming the debt clearance, signed it, and stamped it. That was it. One business handshake, thanking each other. And they went away. That was it.

"..."

The mountain of debt was paid off, but Lloyd wondered if this was what he was supposed to feel. Nothing. He felt nothing. Instead of joy, there was emptiness, a sense of detachment from reality, and a tad bit of resignation. Lloyd couldn't point out whether this was normal.

"I thought it would be a little different," Lloyd said to himself aloud.

Lloyd did imagine what it would be like to pay off the debt before. Actually, he had imagined it hundreds of times, and it started before he came to the barony. Back when he used to live in a cramped dorm room, he vaguely envisioned how his life would have turned out if his family had paid off their entire debt. The same fantasy crossed his mind before his parents passed away. The thought of him winning the lottery and clearing their debt in one payment, and traveling with his parents had put a big smile on his face.

I have never ever felt empty in any of my fantasies.

But right now, when the moment he once thought would be filled with infinite joy arrived, he just scoffed at how meaningless it all was. But because people around him were joyful, Lloyd at least could accept that his debt was cleared.

"Ha! Hahaha! My… My...!"

It was the first time Lloyd saw the baron be this joyful. The baron couldn’t finish his words. He simply kept swallowing the words, trembling as he spoke. And as his emotions were too strong to come out into words, he finally gave up and jumped to hug Lloyd, patting him for a long time. And the baroness gazed at Lloyd, tears welling up in her eyes as though she was praising him for a job well done.

“...”

Lloyd was reminded of the gaze his father gave him in his dream. Aside from the baron and baroness, many others came to visit him, sending a host of praises for clearing their debt.

“Master Lloyd, you are truly amazing. No one would have pulled that off so easily.”

“I was absurd for forming wrong ideas about you. I respect you so much, Master Lloyd.”

Lloyd could feel the sincerity of the administrator and Sir Bayern in their messages. Aside from them, the servants and maids he bumped into on the corridor and the farmers he came across on the road praised him highly in various manners.

The news surely spreads fast.

The debt was paid off in the afternoon, and it was only three or four hours since the loan sharks went away. But every corner of the fiefdom was already noisy from the news. Congratulations. I’m proud of you. Loyd had never been praised so much in his life. Thanks to it, he earned a new title.

Ding Dong.

[You have paid off a massive amount of debt through your wit, grit, and hard work.]

[Everyone who encountered the news is overwhelmed by adoration and praising you very much.]

[You have earned a new title <The Eldest Son of the Frontera Family>.]

[The Eldest Son of the Frontera Family.]

[Title Level: Regional talk]

There are times when you incur a loan or take on debt. But you see... When misfortune sweeps over your life, when crippling debt burden your shoulders, you and many others will despair. You and many others will berate destiny and bad luck. That isn't bad. Perhaps, it's only natural. Anyone would react that way. That is why he is so great. No one had trusted him. Everyone considered him to be impossible. And yet, he didn't despair and gave up easily. So, my son, when the weight of life seems to crush you down, look toward his accomplishment. For potential is always present in everyone.

[Compliment Effect: You have attained the highest financial credit ranking in the Cremona region. You can now acquire an investment in the most advantageous conditions and with the lowest interest rate available at any time. Moreover, no one will pressure you for an investment or any form of a loan.]

[Active Period of Title: Lifetime]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 2]

[Current CP: 2]

The effect was appallingly great. Plus, it was to last for a lifetime. Lloyd would have hurray-ed on any other day. But not today. He couldn't wrap his head around why he was perturbed. After throwing a quick glance at the message window, he closed it and called for the person walking beside him.

"Hey."

"Yes, Master Lloyd."

"What was your father like?" asked Lloyd.

“...”

Lloyd felt Javier staring at him. A smile escaped him.

“Just. I just was curious. I’m sorry if it’s private, and I crossed the line.”

“Are you okay...?” Javier asked, his voice dripping with doubt.

“Yes.”

“But how do you explain your quick apology?”

“No reason. Everyone has weird days,” Lloyd said nonchalantly.

Yes. There were days when everyone acted strangely. The same went for Lloyd. Today was the rare day when he felt like he was back to being Suho Kim, not Lloyd Frontera. The day when he felt like he had breathed in after taking off a mask on his face.

“He was a rough man...”

Javier’s voice pierced into Lloyd’s ears. Sounding low and heavy, Javier continued to talk, but it went on like a soliloquy.

“Actually, I was too young when I last saw him. I have a vague and hazy image of him like I am seeing him through several layers of glass placed on one another. But there is one thing I can recall, and it’s that he was very much of a rough man,” Javier said.

“Why do you remember so?”

“Because he used to tap my back right before I went to bed at night, and that’s all I can recall.”

A smile spread on Javier against the rays of sunset.

“He was a busy man. It was hard to see him. I waited all day long until I dozed off. I had to pretend I was asleep until midnight because I didn’t want to get scolded by my mother.”

“Your father came back at midnight?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd wondered where Javier was gazing at. The deepening dusk? A past memory?

“He worked his head off late in the day, and he came back only at midnight. Then, he would tap my back several times with his soil-soaked hand as I pretended to sleep. That is all I can remember. The callous touch of his large palm. The roughness in his clumsy tapping... Such things,” Javier said.

“Yes, I see.”

Maybe we’re very similar, Lloyd said to himself. Not a word was exchanged with Javier after that. Instead, they walked side by side at the same stride. Sometimes, their pace turned slow or uniform at times. They continued to walk for a long while until they came back to the manor. And like any other day, Lloyd had dinner, helped Javier fall asleep, and returned to his bedroom.

“Whew.”

His routine was similar to any other day, but something was different. This day was passing by. But Lloyd was still unsure about his emotions.

It’s really funny. Really.

A scoff tried to escape him, but Lloyd suppressed it. He stared at the pitch-black ceiling, and memories began to appear one by one in his head. They opened up like an old journal. His childhood days. His parents. His dire family situation. Their unbearable mountain of debt. And his parents’ hunched backs, which were crushed by the weight of the debt.

It’s really funny. Really.

Another laughter escaped him. But for some reason. His nose continued to burn. He wished he would dream the same, just like last night. If he did, he

wanted to tell his father this.

Dad, I think I made it in this place...

And for the first time after arriving in this world, he cried.

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Chapter 120: Joyful Day (2)

Cocka-doodle-doo!

Lloyd's eyes flew open at the sound that announced the coming of the morning.

"Woah."

Lloyd rubbed his eyes immediately and erased every trace of his dream the other night. He washed up his face like usual, had breakfast, and woke Javier up. Javier woke up to stare at Lloyd at length.

"Did you cry last night by any chance?" blurted Javier.

"What?"

"Your eyes are swollen and somewhat bloodshot."

"Oh, that?" said Lloyd as he put on a smile in a hurry. "I had trouble sleeping last night. Seriously, my heart was just pounding like an earthquake last night."

"Your heart? Why?" asked Javier.

"Yeah, my heart. My heart raced when I thought about all the comforts I'll be enjoying from now on," said Lloyd.

It was true. A day of melancholy was enough. He had more days ahead of him for enjoyment. Days without any financial debt. A financially clean life was about to begin.

"Think about it. I paid off the debt. And the fiefdom is running very well. And the viscounty is paying us for the water every month," enumerated Lloyd.

That was true as well. As he enumerated, he confirmed once again that the future for the barony was bright and clear. It was practically surrounded by

stable sources of income.

“Even though there is a bit of damage from the locust swarm in the Maritz Land, it’s no problem. Do you remember that the locust carcasses got turned into soot by Bangul? We ground them to fine dust and sprinkled them on the ground, and jackpot.”

“Do you mean that you used it as fertilizer?”

“Yeah, I heard that pepper, corn, and all the other crops are growing well these days,” Lloyd said.

“Hmm, that is good news,” Javier replied.

“And it looks like the orc tribe has settled down already.”

“Right, I had heard the news as well. I heard that they are very content as their new home near Lake Kapua is littered with game animals.”

“You’re right, and Bibeong is doing a good job too.”

The 328-foot fantastical creature was splashing around in Lake Kapua, dutifully letting out a ferocious roar twice every day, day and night each. Lloyd’s request was being faithfully granted. The credit was due to Bangul, Bibeong’s first love.

“Anyway, so I’m absolutely free from worry. I’ll be living in luxury for the rest of my life. So I was thinking of throwing a festival.”

“A festival?” asked Javier.

“Well, to celebrate paying off the debt and defending the monster invasion. Don’t we celebrate Thanksgiving around this time anyway? So the timing is good as well.”

“I think it’s a good idea,” seconded Javier.

“Good idea? You’re complimenting me...? Why?”

“No reason. Everyone has off days,” Javier said.

“Really?”

“Really.”

Javier faintly grinned at Lloyd’s side. He had grown softer in the past days. Lloyd figured that it was because his likeability surpassed zero and became positive.

“Anyway, I’m planning on suggesting the idea to the baron.”

Lloyd headed to the baron’s office and suggested holding a festival. The baron, as always, gave him a yes.

“The idea is indeed splendid in my ears. On top of that, why don’t we take a family trip after the festival is over?” the baron suggested.

“Excuse me? A trip?” asked Lloyd, not sure whether he heard it right.

“Yes, a trip,” the baron said and let out a chuckle. “We used to enjoy a family trip once every year or two, but that stopped when that happened. Do you not remember?”

“Oh...”

Lloyd figured that the baron was referring to the crippling debt. His thought was confirmed when he heard the baron next.

“So this is our chance. We never dared to travel when we were in debt, and we overcame a huge disaster recently.”

The baron’s face beamed in joy as he spoke. He continued to speak at length, but most of them were about the trip, and how certain places are perfect in weather like this. He paraded his plans for the family trip as though it was already confirmed and decided.

“Yes. I agree with it as well,” said Lloyd.

“Is that so?” asked the baron.

“Yes, but all planning--”

“Don’t you worry about it, and leave it to me. If there is anyone who can plan a trip, it’s me.”

“Hahaha, is that so?”

“Yes, yes, of course, I am.”

The baron tapped his chest in bravado, and the sight brought a smile to Lloyd’s face.

A family trip?

Lloyd wondered when was the last time he had gone on a family trip. He couldn’t remember it properly.

College? Orientation? Wait, that wasn’t a family trip.

When he searched his memory, the only time he had gone on a happy family trip was when he was a child. He tried to think of the time when he had traveled after he grew up. But nothing came to his mind.

And for the last few years, I have never had the time to travel.

It was true. Ever since he was brought into this world, he worked his head off day in and day out. Always on the move, Lloyd was slammed with work to pay off his debt.

I traveled to Cremo and to the royal capital, but that can’t be considered a trip.

They were there for official business, so it couldn’t be considered a trip. The same went for when he was in the other world.

It was worse there. I just rotted away in my rental room.

Taking a trip was a luxury for Lloyd. All he could afford was to take a suburb bus to a random destination, but that alone burdened him. One time, Lloyd yearned to see the east sea and just gaze at the sea. Just a simple day trip. Life was too stifling for him, and his heart was going to burst soon. But he decided to give up on it. Why? Simple. he had no money for the round fare. To be precise, spending money on the bus ride meant he would have no money for his rent.

I was miserable.

He felt wretched on the way home due to only a few dollars. But now, it was different. The barony was loaded now, and as long as no one lived in extravagance and splurged the money all away, the wealth promised a lifetime of stable merriment and abundance.

“Then, I shall look forward to it.”

Lloyd’s steps felt light as he walked out of the office. The feeling went on even when he was enjoying the festival.

This is what it feels like to live.

Delicious food. A life free from labor. Kind and smiling people. Lloyd wondered if this was what it was like to live in heaven. Such a festival lasted for three days.

So comfortable.

Having grown bored with the festive mood, Lloyd spent his whole day goofing around in his bedroom. He read several books he had picked out from the library and spent a lazy and relaxed day.

I want to play a video game.

Lloyd recalled the free games he had enjoyed back in South Korea. There was nothing better than video games to kill boredom and time.

Should I learn to hunt?

This time, the hunting would be real, not virtual. He feared that he would get fat unless he did so. When he was having such thoughts on a sofa, there came a knock on his door.

Knock knock.

“Master Lloyd. Are you inside?”

Javier’s voice was heard along with the face, and Lloyd replied aloud, still lying down on the sofa.

“Yes, I’m in here. Come in--”

“You need to see this.”

“You’re already inside...”

Lloyd removed the book covering his face, and then he saw the grim expression on Javier’s face. It wasn’t the kind he always had on his face every day. Something was off, and Lloyd noticed it right away as he had spent considerable time with Javier.

“What is it...?”

A mischievous joke? No. Whatever it was, something happened. And indeed, Javier’s following response was suggestive.

“I do not know how to put it into words.”

“Then?”

“I think you need to see this for yourself.”

“...”

Lloyd followed Javier as the latter stepped out of the manor and went down to the center of the fiefdom. It was still festive there as the festival was on the third day. But now...

Something's unsettled here.

The melodious lute and singing were not there anymore, and it was replaced by a group of people murmuring. And their gaze was all darted to one side.

Who are those people?

Everyone's gaze was fixated on a group of 70 to 80 people. But they were all dressed in a similar fashion, but not because they were soldiers in uniform or robbers from a troupe. They were instead all ragged. The clothes were dirty and threadbare. Their knees were patchy, and the sleeves were torn. And their flesh revealed in between their tattered clothes were skins and bones. And their feet, they were more wretched. Only a handful of people wore what looked like a pair of shoes. Most of them seemed to have walked a great distance with nothing but a piece of cloth tied around their feet, which were caked with pus, soil, and dust. Their shirts and coats would have been decent if they were new, but they were not.

What the...

In short, they were haggard-looking with their sunken eyes and cheeks. And their hair was caked together in sweat and dust. And their worn-out faces. Lloyd passed his residents and walked over to the ragged people.

"Excuse me, do you, by any chance, live in this fiefdom?"

Lloyd didn't recognize anybody. But he asked just to be safe. The answer he received wasn't surprising.

"N-no, young master. Are you the owner of this fiefdom?"

"I am not the owner," Lloyd replied.

"Then, you are-"

"The owner's son."

"Oh."

The guy, who appeared to be the representative and just over 30 years old, spoke as he gazed at Lloyd with yearning.

“I am truly sorry to ask you this, but... young master, please help us.”

“Hmm.”

“These children are dying of hunger,” the man went on. “I do not ask for much. No, even animal feed will do. Please you don't have to feed the adults, just the children. Please, I ask for your favor, young master,” the man whimpered as he bowed. Then the entire group bowed in the same fashion. Lloyd let out a sigh.

“Woah.”

Lloyd wondered who these men and women were and where they came from. For a split second, he considered them to be beggars. But the number was too many to be so, not to mention the varying age groups.

“We have enough to feed you all, so pull yourself together first. Okay? But first, I think you and I need to talk,” Lloyd suggested.

“Talk...?” The man muttered in hesitation.

“I don’t bite. I’ll get you some things to bite into instead.”

“Ah... I understand.”

The man rose and strode toward Lloyd, who requested his people to bring out some water, soup, and a light snack, and clothe them up. Afterward, he took the leader to one side and spoke.

“I’ll be straightforward with you. Who are you people?” demanded Lloyd.

A group of ragged-looking individuals appeared out of nowhere to break the festive mood in the fiefdom. There was something awkward and off about that. Lloyd even considered the possibility of some being foreign espionage. But what the man said caught Lloyd by surprise.

“We are from Sortino barony. And my name is Nicholas, and I come from a village named Sorti in the fiefdom. My father used to be the chief, but because of the recent disaster-”

“Hold on. People from Sortino barony? You all are?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes. That is right.”

“What are you doing here then? And in this state? And what do you mean by disaster?” asked Lloyd, feeling confused at the odd situation.

The Sortino barony sits quite south of ours.

Lloyd couldn’t wrap his head around how these people ended up here in his fiefdom in such a sordid state. But the answer was in the man’s response.

“Monsters attacked our village,” said Nicholas.

“What...?”

“It was a great number of monsters. What was the name...? Herakleto? It looked similar to a beetle that went over 60 feet in size... They swarmed on us like bees, nibbling all the trees and grass in sight.”

“What are you saying...”

“We lost our land as a result. But we never gave up. Encouraged by our lord, we tried to put up shacks and work on our fields again. But the heavens abandoned us,” Nicholas said grimly.

“It couldn’t be,” replied Lloyd.

“Yes, young master. That is right. Five days after we were swept by Herakleto, another monster herd invaded my village.”

“...”

Lloyd was speechless. He knew what had happened there.

“Monster domino...” Lloyd muttered.

“Excuse me?”

“No, never mind. So what happened to your lord?”

“He went missing while he fought against the monster herds that came after. We presume that...”

“He was eaten up,” Lloyd finished on Nicholas’s behalf.

“Yes...” Nicholas answered with a grim expression on his face.

“The lord and his family went missing. There was nothing we could do in that situation. Everyone fled for their lives, and more than half of them perished. And finally, we managed to come here...”

“It must have been a hard journey coming here.”

“Yes...” The man said, and he finally broke into tears.

At last, Lloyd was enlightened about what had happened.

Yes. The Sartino Barony. It sits far south of us. But what stands in its east? The eastern mountain range. Just like ours.

The strip of mountain range extended a long way. The north and south were a couple thousand of miles apart. And so, the Frontera barony wasn’t the only one that sat in the vicinity of the eastern range. Dozens of fiefdoms were there, and...

Most of the fiefdoms close to the eastern range would have fallen within the influence of the monster domino.

Lloyd was aware of such a fact, but he didn’t have the time and confidence to help out others. He had figured that the other lords, who do a pretty good job at managing their fiefdoms, would handle the situation well. But now, he learned that it wasn’t the case.

They don’t have fantastical creatures, me, a sword master, an engineering corp, or lancers dispatched by the queen.

Without these capabilities, would there be any fiefdom that could well fend itself from the invasion? The answer was no.

“Eat first. And make yourselves warm,” Lloyd said.

“Oh, thank you so much, young master. I shall never forget your favor-”

“Don’t bring up the favor to me now. It makes me uncomfortable. Stay here a few days, and move to another fiefdom once you get better.”

Lloyd left the table without waiting for a response, but did he do so because he feared Nicholas would bug him? Or because he had completely forgotten his harsh days when he was penniless and poor? No. That was all wrong.

This may mean that more refugees may come here with no end in sight.

Lloyd strode toward the baron’s office after he removed himself from the disrupted festival. His steps were quick now. The same thing was happening in his head. Lloyd awakened every single neuron that rested for the past few days, meticulously going over the days ahead of his barony.

At least 20 fiefdoms would have been ruined to dust. Where would those refugees rush to? To the west? No. Another mountain range is there, so they can’t cross it. To the south? It’s a foreign country. And they won’t go to the east since monsters flooded from there.

As such, the only direction left for them was the north, and the only functional fiefdom in the northern route would be here, the Frontera barony. Moreover, the days were turning cold as winter was approaching.

Traveling to Cremo would be too much without food and proper clothes. So that means...

In the northern route the refugees would take, there was only one fiefdom that survived. And it was close enough for them to dare travel by foot.

Us. Who else? Just us. There's nowhere else.

Lloyd gritted his teeth as he concluded that a huge number of refugees would rush here. But turning a blind eye to them and kicking them out would bring about serious punishments from the queen.

My goodness, I guess I'm not destined to take a vacation. Dammit.

Lloyd bitterly wondered when he would ever have the luxury of comfort to rest and live the life of Riley. Feeling the bitter taste of his destiny, Lloyd hurried toward the baron's office. And throughout his walk there, in his head, there formed an urgent city planning that could accommodate an inundating number of refugees.

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Chapter 121: Milking Money (1)

“It appears we will be busy for a while, my lord,” said Lloyd.

“Eh?”

Screech!

The abrupt voice seemingly broke the silence. The baron tightened his fingers, and his chisel skidded forward. The wooden doll in his other hand received a long scratch as a result.

“Oops, oh my...”

But his wistful look quickly disappeared. The baron removed his gaze from the sculpture and turned to Lloyd.

“What do you mean that we will be busy?” asked the baron.

“Forget that, are you okay?”

“Oh, I’m okay. I meant to peel off the area anyway, so it is all fine. And my hand didn’t get injured,” said the baron.

“That’s a relief.”

Lloyd was actually feeling the opposite of what he said. The baron had discontinued his hobby of chiseling wooden dolls when he was pressed under crippling debt. But now that the debt was paid off and the crisis in his family was nonexistent, his habit returned to ensure a peaceful merriment in his daily life. However, such a joyful hobby was set to be put on hold for a moment again.

“Refugees have come to our fiefdom,” Lloyd explained.

“What?” The baron was about to pick up the chisel to smoothen the area but stopped. “What refugees?”

“Just as I said. There are about 80 refugees here,” explained Lloyd.

“Have you checked where they are from?”

“Yes, they’re from the Sortino barony.”

“What? Hold on. Sortino barony is...” The baron looked at Lloyd meaningfully.

“Yes, it’s near the eastern range. Just like us.”

“...”

The baron’s eyes gradually grew bigger as the meaning of Lloyd’s words slowly sunk into him.

“Unfortunately, they failed to respond to the monster domino,” Lloyd said. “The entire fiefdom became desolated.”

“What about the Sortino family?”

“They have gone missing,” Lloyd said, his voice low.

“What a tragedy...”

“I had people serve up warm water and food to the refugees first. So, I have something to tell you, my lord,” said Lloyd, hurrying up before the baron’s face grew darker. “It appears that more refugees will be coming soon.”

“Yes, I see. That is the reason why you said we will be busy soon,” replied the baron.

“Yes.”

“But what about the other fiefdoms? Any news?”

“No. But...”

“But?”

“I presume that most of them met the same fate as the Sortino barony.”

“...”

The baron shut his mouth. It was hard, but it was plausible enough because he, too, experienced firsthand the shock and terror of the monster domino when hundreds of thousands of locusts stormed into his fiefdom.

Yes, there would only be a few... that could defend themselves against such a terrorizing event...

The baron still suffered from nightmares of that day. He broke out in a cold sweat on those nights, and he would wake up from sleep completely soaked. And so, he didn’t take the matter in front of him lightly.

Clack.

The baron put down the wooden doll and chisel.

“So... are you saying that those refugees will come to our fiefdom?”

“Yes, my lord.”

“How many?”

“Almost all of them.”

“What?” The baron threw a glance at Lloyd.

“The ballpark number is somewhere between thousands. It may easily go over tens of thousands.”

The baron’s eyes widened in surprise. The number was somewhere between thousands and tens of thousands. The baron, who had braced himself to hear the figure, was shocked to hear the actual number. His surprise made sense, for the Frontera barony boasted less than 5,000 people in population. And right now, his son was notifying him that a group of refugees was expected to arrive, and the number was a couple of times more than the current population in the barony.

“But... even so, do you really think it will happen?” said the baron.

“I presume it will.”

“...”

The baron’s Adam’s apple bobbed when he gulped. Lloyd was always right. It seemed so looking back. There was never a time he was at a loss when he did whatever his son suggested. Putting faith in Lloyd rendered a host of benefits. The same thing would be with the refugee situation. Plus, there was enough evidence to trust his son’s words.

“You’re right,” the baron agreed, “Come to think of it, you do have a point.”

The baron began to collect his thoughts as he spoke.

“Most of the fiefdoms near the eastern range have probably been greatly damaged. The same is true for the fiefdoms sitting in the west.”

“Yes, that is likely.”

“Right,” said the baron, “there must not be many places for the refugees to turn to.”

“Yes, my lord. Another range sits further into the west, and the south is a foreign country,” said Lloyd.

“And since they won’t be able to move to the east because that’s where the monsters came from, their only option is the north...”

“And in their route, the only working fiefdom would be us and the Lacona viscounty. There is also Cremo, the central city of this province. But it’s too far.”

“Right,” said the baron, “and making things worse, winter is nearing. From the perspective of the refugees, traveling to Cremo would be extremely difficult.”

“Yes. They will flock to a place where they can safely spend the winter.”

“And that would be our fiefdom.”

“Yes.”

A soft smile escaped him. Truly, the baron was a sensible person. He slightly lacked the grit to overcome challenges, but he gave ears to the advice of people around him. In a situation like this, such quality was imperative.

“And so, I think we need to prepare for two things before more people flood in here.”

“Two things?”

“The most urgent ones would be providing food and shelter when accommodating the refugees.”

“Food and shelter. Hmm.” The baron’s expression became dark.

“I suppose we must halt the festival first since we should save as much food as we can. But that still won’t be enough to feed thousands of refugees.”

It was true. The food stocked up in the storage wasn’t enough to feed the refugees. Sure, the Maritz land finally saw harvest, but there was still room for improvement as this was the first time the land was being refurbished and worked. The harvest was only enough to cover the people in the fiefdom. So right now, a flood of refugees whose number was set to reach multiple times their current population was far from promising.

“Should we resort to importing from Cremo?” the baron suggested the first thing that came to his mind.

“Well, that is a great idea as well. But I wish to leave it as the next best alternative.”

“Do you have any ideas in mind then?” asked the baron.

“Yes.”

“What is it?”

“Locusts. The bugs Bangul caught with her volcanic ash.”

The baron’s facial expression froze.

“What...? Do you mean to say we should feed the refugees the locust carcasses?”

What if they throw it up in disgust? Or what if they blow their gaskets and stir up a riot? Those were the two questions that popped into the baron’s head. But such a reaction was only natural because eating a locust was unimaginable and foreign to the people in the Laurasian continent. However, it wasn’t to Lloyd, who was from South Korea.

I mean, locusts may look repulsive, but grill them up well, and they become a great bar snack.

Plus, most South Koreans enjoyed pupas as snacks. So Lloyd and the baron had differing perspectives on consuming insects.

“It is all right. They won’t die eating it. The locusts should be surprisingly tasty. Not to mention the fact that they’re very nutritious.”

“But still, they’re insects...”

“Plus, they’re not small bugs. So that would be even better for us,” reasoned Lloyd.

“What do you mean by that?” asked the baron.

“The refugees won’t be eating up the entire thing.”

A corner of Lloyd’s lips curved upward.

“The locusts are over 2 feet in size. Snap the head and legs, and tear the skin naked. It’d be about a foot and a half. That is why...”

“So?” the baron asked in expectation.

“There is no one who can consume an entire locust in one sitting. Isn’t it comparable to the size of a steak?”

“Oh...”

The baron’s eyes glimmered. He was starting to get the idea.

“You plan on chopping only the meaty parts to feed them, yes?”

“Yes, that is what I mean.”

The corners of Lloyd’s lips pulled further up. Human psychology worked like that. Cooking something up and seeing the ingredients in their raw form repulsed humans. They either loved or hated it, nothing in between. And so many ingredients were chopped and sliced into most dishes to hide their original shapes. Moreover, these refugees weren’t mukbang streamers or food fighters. No one among them would be eating a raw 1.5-foot-long locust as it would be processed and cut up into small pieces before being served.

“But of course, that wouldn’t entirely get rid of the repulsion toward the locust meat. So we have to come up with a recipe,” said Lloyd.

“A recipe? Why?” asked the baron in curiosity.

“Since a recipe is just a thing to make the refugees enjoy them,” Lloyd said as he shrugged. “Now, let’s get moving, my lord. We need to take care of the urgent matters first.”

“Yes, that sounds like a good idea.” The baron nodded at the same. If the refugees were right about their testimony and if Lloyd was right in his prediction, there was not a second to lose.

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The barony carefully moved in preparation for the incoming refugees. First was the processing of locust meats attained in mass. They were already

grilled to a crisp by the volcanic explosion, and the cold climate preserved them to be of the best quality. Javier oversaw the process.

“Okay, I want you guys to follow me. From here to here. Like this.”

Javier demonstrated with a dagger, and the crispy locust was skinned in a flash, exposing a white meat likened to a shrimp.

“It’s easy, right?”

“...”

But it was never easy. The guard soldiers struggled to peel off the skin. Once only the juicy meat was left, the fiefdom’s women, who were supervised by Baroness Marbella, took over.

“Actually, I had a taste a while ago,” the baroness said in a dignified manner.

Her words caused the other women to widen their eyes in surprise, unable to internalize that the baroness had tasted those creepy and disgusting locusts before anyone else.

“Yes, I did. I chewed and ate it. It was not so bad,” she added.

“...”

“Based on my experience, I think we need a bit of a strong spice. This meat was a bit gamey. That is why...” The baroness grinned elegantly and placed an old book on the countertop.

“I am sure you are familiar with this cookbook. Yes, this is the legendary cookbook ‘I Became the Dragon King’s Chef’ any refined and high-status lady owns or wants to own.”

“Oh, my!”

There was an envious clamor among the women. It was only natural, given that the cookbook had been regarded as one of the best of the best

cookbooks on the continent for several hundred years. It was a legendary and rare cookbook authored by a foreign girl who became the wife of a dragon in human form eons ago.

“Yes, it is the cookbook you all are familiar with,” Marbella explained, “I am sure you can recall how my son had taken care of the dark sorcerer the last time. He brought it from the evil man’s den. It is my plan to refer to this book to develop a recipe for cooking locusts. What do you say to that?”

“…!” The women nodded their heads in enthusiasm.

Amid the busy preparation in the fiefdom, Lloyd’s days were hectic as well. But his business was different in nature. He was busy walking, which went on for a whole day. Every day, without fail, he aimlessly walked and walked as though he was possessed by a spirit that loved strolling. At times, he stopped and nodded. Other times, he looked around, sighed, and contemplated. Just like that, Lloyd walked, observed, and walked every corner of the fiefdom for several days. It was as if he had become Anaximander, the first mapmaker in the world. But none of the residents thought his behavior was strange.

“He must have a reason. After all, he is Master Lloyd.”

“Of course. He is Master Lloyd.”

“Indeed. He is Master Lloyd.”

The troublemaker, the gangster, worse-than-a-plague hooligan young master was gone in their perception. In its stead, his actions were defined and understood in one sentence: He is Master Lloyd. That was enough. Even if Lloyd did handstands all day or tumbled forward and backward and jumped around, everyone was almost ready to understand him, saying, “He is Master Lloyd.”

Regardless, about 15 days passed by. Lloyd’s prediction turned real. Each day, more refugees fled into the barony on and on. There was no end. Some were in groups of ten while others came in hundreds. Men and women

came from all corners of the east. The refugees began to be packed full in the fiefdom. Once this truly happened, the baron paled.

“What do we do?”

On the morning of the 16th day the refugees arrived, the baron called Lloyd, and he spoke in a voice mixed with anxiety.

“Whew... I somehow braced myself for this to happen after you told me, but as I see the endless queue of people, my heart is afraid.”

It was the indisputable truth. He did see this coming, for he was warned of the massive influx of refugees. So he decided to stay prepared and determined. But when he actually confronted the situation with his own eyes, this whole thing felt real. The actual situation turned out to be much worse than what he vaguely imagined. He felt frustration bubbling over inside him.

“Yes, we made various preparations on our end, like the locust meat, but I am afraid,” the baron confessed. “I am worried about whether we can take care of them. Or I wonder if we should take in a certain number of them and send the rest away. Will we be able to offer them a place to stay safe against the cold wind? I couldn’t get a wink of sleep last night.”

“Hmm, is that so?”

“Yes. How am I supposed to accept this situation...? On that note, I heard that you have been walking across all around the fiefdom. Tell me, did you find the solution to solve this shelter problem which you kept to yourself the last time?”

The baron recalled the report he had heard a few days ago about how Lloyd spent the whole day roaming around the fiefdom. So the baron figured that Lloyd was doing what he called surveying, that he was devising a housing plan he vaguely mentioned the last time. The baron’s presumption was right.

“Yes, I do have a plan, my lord.”

“I knew you would have one,” the baron said. “That is great. Tell me, what is this plan?”

“Other than obviously providing a temporary tent, ultimately...”

“Ultimately?” The baron asked again, still hopeful.

Lloyd grinned happily and said, “Have you ever heard of an apartment complex?”

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Chapter 122: Milking Money (2)

An apartment complex. It was the most common type of residence in South Korea. It was ubiquitous in cities near the capital, metropolitan cities, and even in provincial towns. The housing structure was so rampant that not having them in a city was the same as not having kimchi during dinner. That was how a stately apartment complex was in South Korea. Lloyd, too, lived in one of them when he was there.

From the moment I was in elementary school. Until my house was auctioned off.

His family lived in the typical 112 square meter unit with one living room and three rooms. The veranda lined up the plants his father used to grow, and the walls boasted the ostentatious wallpapers of his mother’s taste. They were tacky by today’s standards, but still, Lloyd wished to go back to that cozy house if he could. He sometimes even dreamed of living there. Even the faint scent of the cleaner that wafted out every time his mother cleaned the bathroom stimulated his nose in his dream. To Lloyd, the house was to be missed and a source of nostalgia.

But of course, I’m not thinking of putting that kind of apartment here.

The conditions weren't right to build one here, and there really wasn’t any reason to do so. The apartment complex he was suggesting to construct on this land was meant to efficiently accommodate refugees.

“And so, I was trying to find a solution and thought over the issue. How I can efficiently and safely accommodate as many people in a limited space.”

“Hmm, so your conclusion was this so-called apartment complex?”

“Yes.”

The baron cocked his head to the side as he failed to understand Lloyd. He appeared to be slightly confused by the unfamiliar term he had never heard before. Lloyd nodded his head earnestly toward the baron.

“To be honest, the concept didn’t come from me. Do you recall the time I had stopped by at the academy to meet Julian during my time at the capital?”

“Mhm, yes, you did.”

“While I waited for Julian, I came across the concept from a book shelved in one of the many bookshelves in the academy.”

Of course, it was a lie. There was no book, and he had never seen such. But the baron had no way of verifying it. Besides, Lloyd knew that he could resort to a white lie in a moment like this. And he could always brush it away saying that the book wasn’t there anymore.

“The book introduced architecture styles of the ancient kingdoms,” lied Lloyd.

“So, are you saying that this ‘apartment complex’ is architecture conceptualized in ancient times?” asked the baron.

“Yes, that is what I mean.”

Lloyd grinned. This time, he wasn’t lying. It was the truth except for that it was an ancient architectural style of the earth, not this Lorasian continent.

“Though the name isn’t famous, there once was an empire named ‘Rome.’ And the empire held several multi-story residential buildings called the Insula, which housed many families.”

“Insula?”

“Yes, my lord. The building was constructed from wood, brick, and classical cement. The limit is usually six stories to avoid any collapsing, but some were even constructed up to more than ten.”

“Haha, ten stories?”

“That’s just not it. There was also a country named Islam other than Rome. A city named Cairo was lined up with seven-story apartments, and hundreds

of people lived in one building, according to the record," Lloyd expounded.

"Hundreds in one building, eh?"

"Yes," Lloyd replied. "Some even reached 14 stories, and the roof even held a garden."

"Haha. It must have looked like a royal palace," the baron stated.

"Needless to say. In particular, a place called 'Shibam' in Yemen is recorded to have boasted an apartment unit that was 11 stories high while entirely made of dirt."

"Hmm," the baron said as he stroked his chin, "That means that you will vertically construct a building high to accommodate refugees in a limited land space, yes?"

"Yes, that's what I mean."

Lloyd smiled with conviction as he taught the baron a completely new concept of construction. In a moment like this, putting on a confident air was imperative.

Duh. In a situation like this, I must appeal to people even if it means lying to them. That's how I can advance in society.

Just then, his mind flew back to the time in South Korea. It really was the case even in a simple setting such as a construction field where dust and cement powders flew all around. He had to pose and show up to earn rewards, even if it demanded him to be political. In construction sites, those who received praise and got recruited for being competent were mostly those who actively publicized their skills to others. In other words, a combination of dexterity and sales skills promised greater physical and monetary rewards than those without the latter.

It's the same right now.

He must own a silver tongue and make his audience look forward to the outcome. As such, Lloyd licked his lips and resolved to turn himself into a

salesman.

“First and foremost, there are many advantages to constructing an apartment complex. One of them is the easier administrative management of the refugees,” Lloyd began.

“Do explain for me, will you?”

“Yes,” Lloyd replied. “Imagine that a building accommodates 1,000 residents. Then we will be able to create a management system where a leader will be selected in a unit of 1,000 residents to count the numbers, check their health, and provide relief goods.”

“Hmm, that sounds like a good idea. What is the second benefit?”

“Since a lot of people will reside in a house that stands up vertically, the actual land mass required to accommodate an individual will be reduced. Don’t you think this is quite appealing given the fiefdom’s rather modest territory? This one is related to the third benefit,” Lloyd went on.

“Yes, do go on,” the baron urged.

“Yes. Once the refugees settle down here, business districts will develop around the apartment complex in the future.”

“What do you mean by business districts? Like bars, shops, and restaurants?”

“That is right. An area will be created thanks to the increase in population density caused by the apartment complex. A high population in a small area means that the purchasing power in the region will be high.”

That was exactly the case in South Korea. Very much so. Businesses thrived around apartment complexes. As the population focused on a small area, the purchasing power increased as a result, and movie theaters, franchise restaurants and cafes, after school classes, hospitals, supermarkets, salons, and convenience stores appeared everywhere. The population tempted the businessmen and women to do business there.

“There is one more thing. It’s easy to construct.”

“How so?” asked the baron.

“Because it will be standardized.”

Lloyd shrugged after he spoke.

“Once hundreds of families come in for a while, the hundreds of houses will be shaped in the same fashion, like they are printed. Standardized houses are easier to construct and manage. Moreover, it’s advantageous for insulation as well as during the winter.”

“Insulation?”

“Indeed. Since houses will be surrounded by other houses on all sides. There will be less room for the heat to slip out, keeping the heat during the winter. It’s going to be less cold.”

“I wonder...” The baron nodded in a daze. The advantages Lloyd just enumerated sounded plausible, but the final one Lloyd suggested next appealed to him the most. That was the deal clincher.

“And the last advantage. Our fiefdom will enjoy stronger defense during emergencies.”

“Defense?”

Easy management. Economical land usage. Active businesses. Easier construction and maintenance. And not enough with that, the fiefdom’s defense now? Lloyd grinned as he looked at the widened eyes of the baron. He held up a pen and drew something on a piece of paper. It looked like a donut with an empty middle.

“There is one more ancient architecture style I forgot to tell you a while ago. It’s this one. It’s called ‘Tolou’ in the Fujian province. This is what it looks like. This enclosed building holds a plaza in the center, but my version will look like a four-sided donut, not a round one like this Tolou.”

“This looks like a... fortress.”

“It does, doesn’t it? All the windows are open only toward the inside plaza. This allows the exterior walls to act as a fortress, and the only entrance to the plaza is this one. So if we lock this up, one building will turn into an impregnable fortress.”

“What is the use of the plaza in the center?” asked the baron.

“For communal use.” Lloyd’s voice sounded confident. “I plan on putting only a bedroom and living room in each house. And cooking, eating, washing dishes, doing laundry, showering, and relieving will all take place in the facilities installed in the plaza. The well, canteen, and public sauna, and bathrooms, and whatnot.”

The baron didn’t say a word.

“That is the only way we can house the most number of people there. Like a beehive.”

The baron didn’t say a word.

“Moreover, the advantages I have outlined are just what our fiefdom needs at the moment.”

The baron didn’t say anything again. He simply glanced at his son, feeling slightly dazed. Lloyd put on a brazen smile on his face.

“Certainly,” Lloyd said, “constructing this building will take some time. I will have to find an appropriate piece of land as well as survey and design and acquire materials for the construction. Realistically speaking, it will be completed next winter. That’s the goal. This means that we must build temporary shelters for the refugees before the complex is finished.”

“Yes, I see,” the baron said as he gazed at Lloyd.

“Um, but why are you looking at me like that?”

“Whew, how should I say it? I just think that I am blessed to have you as my son.”

“...”

“Haha, did I make you uncomfortable?”

“Um, it’s not that, but, well, yes, you are making me uncomfortable,” Lloyd said.“And you saying it right at my face makes my stomach churn.”

Lloyd scratched the back of his head. He did throw a pitch to start another project to the baron, but such praise made his face flush red. But the baron continued to send gazes of confidence to Lloyd despite the latter’s evident expression of discomfort. Lloyd was perturbed. Just then, he wondered if there still remained in his heart Suho Kim, the discouraged boy sitting cramped in a small room rental. Lloyd eventually broke into embarrassed laughter.

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A few days passed, and Lloyd gave full-bore efforts to construct temporary shelters for the refugees.

The structure ought to be kept simple as much as possible. So we can finish it in no time.

A square hole was dug 65 feet in width and length and 1.6 feet in depth. Lloyd then constructed a formwork that was the size of a hole, after which he fashioned a zigzag route in it. Each side of the four-sided route was about eight inches in the path. The other end was connected to a chimney. It was a cement ondol to be used for heating.

I didn’t have Bangul or her volcanic explosion skill when I made the ondol room the first time I came here.

During those times, he couldn’t make cement, but now, it was different. Making the ondol floor was much more convenient and safer than before.

It’s all thanks to the surveying skill as well.

Thanks to the design skill and simulation option, Lloyd could test out the flow and discharge of heat, enabling him to construct an ondol structure that can transfer heat in a more sophisticated manner. As such, he was able to easily make one as though he was making some cupcakes.

“Pour!”

“Two, three! Here we go!”

“One, two, oink!”

The civil engineers and orc miners worked together to mix the cement out of Bangul’s volcanic ash and pour it onto the formwork. When it was cured and dried up, a flat ondol surface with an area of 400 square meters was made as a result.

“All right, time to lay the wooden panels!”

“Yes!”

The cement surface was then finished with thin wooden planks, and wooden poles were erected all around. One side was 9.8 feet in height, and the other end was 6.5 feet. They were covered by a thick cloth. Just like that, with the roof sloped to one side, a massive ondol tent was completed.

“All right. You made one already, and I’m sure you now know how it’s done, yes?” asked Lloyd. “From now on, repeat the process. The design and size of the formworks should be equal. Every single one of them. You think you can do it?”

“Of course, we can,” Sir Bayern nodded confidently. Before Lloyd knew it, Sir Bayern had already become so seasoned in commanding the engineering corp that he became an excellent construction supervisor. The job of building the rest of the tents in the winter fell on Sir Bayern. Thanks to it, Lloyd focused on getting ready with constructing the apartment complex.

But the real issue is money.

A scowl never left Lloyd’s face throughout the preparation period. Money really was the actual problem here.

We spent almost all our money to pay off the debt.

Every penny was scraped to clear their debt, so their remaining money reserve was low. Of course, there was the monthly water bill from the Lacona viscounty on top of the steel dungs Bangul excreted that Lloyd was hoping to sell. But none of them could be translated to cash at the moment.

To my relief, the total cost of materials isn’t much. Bangul offers free steel and cement needed for construction. The cost of labor is cheap since I’m hiring the civil engineering corp belonging to the fiefdom. But that doesn’t mean we have plenty of money. I can see how much we lack just by looking at the payment for the stonemasons and blacksmiths we’ll hire later.

Right now, the refugees were flooding into the barony, and that was why the temporary shelters were being constructed. The cost of purchasing tent cloths was considerable, and so Lloyd was already on his uppers to cover the food, medicine, and other basic necessities for the incoming people. Amid this situation, the lack of capital was barely surprising because it took place simultaneously with the unprecedented apartment complex construction.

I need to source some money for this place.

There was a way, in fact. It was to ask help from Count Cremo, and he held the title <The Eldest Son of the Frontera Family> he had newly earned by clearing the debt.

I can attain financial credibility within the Cremona region, and I can get an investment in the most favorable conditions and with the lowest interest rate available. Moreover, no one will press me to pay them back in any form...

That was the effect of the title, so Lloyd could receive a generous investment. But he was hesitant.

I just paid off the debt, and now I have to incur another one?

But this time, no one was going to press him. But since he couldn’t shake off the leery feeling, Lloyd put off the decision and deliberated for a few days. The solution, however, came to him unexpectedly.

“My goodness, Lloyd. Look what just came from the royal capital.”

One afternoon when Lloyd was thinking hard, Baron Frontera called Lloyd to his office. As soon as Lloyd entered, the baron held out a letter.

“What is this?” asked Lloyd as he looked at the letter.

“It’s from the queen.”

Lloyd noticed the royal magic insignia stamped in the letter envelope.

“A carrier pigeon flew here a while ago, and I opened it to find out this. I think we can expect to receive a royal messenger in a few days, bearing the command of the queen.”

“...”

Lloyd took the letter and wondered what it would be about. He opened it.

[Since time immemorial, I, along with the great sovereigns that came before me, have worked hard to achieve peace and comfort for the nobles and citizens. However, the news of great misfortune falling in the stretch of the eastern range has recently been reported to me. My heart is filled with sorrow.]

The letter contained a message about the monster domino that took place in the eastern range. Lloyd continued to read the letter.

[A host of monsters invaded the fiefdoms bordering the east range... Blah blah blah... Many residents lost their lands... Whatnot... The refugees are the people I must cherish.... Blah blah blah... Each fiefdom lord is thus requested to actively accommodate and protect the refugees in the lands I have entrusted you with.]

Hmm...

Lloyd started to deliberate.

[Order. Every fiefdom in the eastern area of the Cremona region is ordered by the powers vested to the queen to prioritize the accommodation and protection of the refugees. November of Year 617. Declared by Queen Alicia Termina Magentano in Magenta the royal capital.]

“Whew. The future looks bleak for us,” the baron sighed beside Lloyd, seeing that his son finished reading the letter.

When Lloyd turned, he realized that the baron’s face darkened. It was grim and gloomy. His emotions were reflected in grumbling.

“Although it is moral to accommodate the refugees, I never expected the queen to issue such an order. What should we do then? What more should we do now when we don’t have enough money or food?”

The baron was being frank. Of course, he had been accepting the incoming refugees for the sake of humanitarianism, but that acceptance could only work when he had enough capacity and resources. Right now, the number of people was overwhelming their tiny barony. Things would have looked brighter if the refugees were equally distributed to the Lacona viscounty that sat on the south. But no. Every single refugee flooded here. Lloyd’s reputation was behind such an influx. The hero of Cremo. The protector of the queen. Two-time defender against the monster invasions. People believed that moving to the Frontera fiefdom would ensure safety, and that thought turned into a beacon of hope and a guide to their escapade.

“And with the queen’s order, we have no choice but to accept every one of them. We cannot even ask for consideration and reject them. Ha... What should we do?”

The baron considered the future to be bleak. He could already see his barony tanking by the financial and refugee crises. Just then...

“Well, this is for the better,” Lloyd calmly said.

“What...?”

Here was the baron’s son, uttering gibberish. But there was more. Lloyd even grinned.

“My dear Lloyd,” the baron asked anxiously, “How could you smile in this dire situation?”

“Oh, of course we should smile.”

“Why?”

“After all, I am joyful.”

“...”

This was it. The surmounting pressure has finally got the better of my smart son, and he has finally lost it, the baron thought to himself.

“Joyful...?” the baron asked, growing more worried. “Why in the world would you feel that?”

“Because I can write a response. That is why I’m happy.”

“A reply?”

“Yes.”

“But to whom?”

“Why, to the queen, of course,” Lloyd said nonchalantly.

“To the queen? You are going to send a response letter to her?”

“Yes,” Lloyd replied with a big fat smile on his face. “This is really for the better. A good thing. Really, a lot has been on my mind because of the financial crisis.”

“And?”

“I am thinking of using my fatal and secret weapon to solve the financial crisis while responding to the queen.”

“What could be that secret weapon of yours that will save our financial state?”

“You see, my lord, the queen herself has just gifted us with permission to use the weapon in her letter.”

“…”

The baron could feel his heart thump, and it dawned on him that his son was on another level compared to him.

I was at a loss when I received the order, but my son saw a glimpse of hope at changing the situation for the better.

He couldn’t be any prouder of his son.

“A hidden weapon?” said the baron as he smothered joy rising in him. “It appears that you have a sure-fire method, given your confidence. What could that be?”

There was anticipation in the baron’s eyes as he asked the question to Lloyd. To this, Lloyd responded with a large and steel-like brazenness on his face.

“Groveling, throwing a tantrum, and whining.”

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Chapter 123: Milking Money (3)

“Ready to fire.”

Creak. Clank! Clank!

In the royal courtyard of Magenta. An officer’s voice rang aloud in the grand drill hall. 50 archers holding a crossbow turned the windlass at the voice. They put the fatal bolt on the string, and the sharp bolt head glinted against the light. Just then, the officer commanded in a serious tone.

“Fire!”

Thwack! Thwack!

More than 50 lethal bolts were fired in unison, each carrying a tension of 1,250 pounds. They flew toward the same target: Queen Alicia Termina Magentano.

“...”

Queen Magentano’s eyes held a glint of ferociousness. The 50 archers that surrounded her were on a more elevated footing than hers, so the arrows were fired at a slanted angle. But it took only a split second to identify the trajectory of each bolt, hear the sound, and feel it. Her response was immediate.

Clank! Slash!

The moment her sword came out of its sheath, strands of her silver aura appeared.

Slash! Crack!

12 sword strikes in one blink. She slashed, struck, slayed upward, defended, spread, twisted, slayed, hit, stabbed, and divided. The aura of twelve strands

roared, surrounding her with a storm, which turned into a soft breeze in no time.

Drop...

50 bolts, which were cut in exactly half, fell to her feet by dozens. But they weren't just sliced in half. Nothing was random. It was cut at the same length and angle. Not a single bolt was exempted. But Queen Magentano looked bored and disinterested because what she did was nothing but some stretching of her muscles.

"Again. This time fire indiscriminately," she ordered dryly.

The officer, who gulped as he saw her, turned toward the archers.

"Reload! Ready to fire!"

Creak. Clank!

The archers busied themselves with reloading and getting ready. Beside them was a pile of hundreds of bolts. This bolt was lethal enough to fatally pierce into heavy armor. Even though she was faced with such an intimidating situation, Queen Magentano breathed with aplomb. It was only obvious as this was her normal training routine, even though it doesn't look like so to others.

This isn't enough.

Queen Magentano told herself that she needed to grow stronger. She needed to get better at sword fighting. It wasn't an option to relax and take things easy just because she rose to the level of a sword master. Otherwise, she could put herself to shame in the future.

I never wish to experience it again.

She recalled that day. The day the suspension bridge was finished. A banquet was held. She drank poison. Sir Kyle attacked her. The mere thought of the event overwhelmed her with shame and rage.

I’d received too much help.

A nameless knight, Javier, overpowered Sir Kyle, who was a sword master. And what about Lloyd, whom she had pegged as a simple young master? He showcased a technique she had never heard of. He absorbed mana around him in an indiscriminate manner and even bore a large hole through the banquet hall roof by emitting some powerful energy. And with what? Just a simple dinner knife.

Whereas I couldn’t do anything.

She was embarrassed by herself. She had gotten too relaxed, boasting that she was already a sword master. But now, ever since she recovered from the poisoning, she had been engrossed in training every day.

There are also several other matters giving me a headache.

She failed to receive any confession from Sir Kyle. Swordmasters had the power to build powerful psychological walls unique to them. Several drugs were put out in his system, and the confession magic was also employed to shatter them to pieces, and the process was likened to digging a thick steel wall with a spoon. But she didn’t give up. Dozens of magicians stuck to the job for almost a month. At last, they succeeded in disarming the psychological wall from Sir Kyle. But what has revealed in his heart frightened the queen.

Sir Kyle was... empty. Completely empty. He knew nothing.

To be technically correct, a part of his memory about the power behind the assassination attempt on the queen and their motivation behind it was completely erased by a powerful brainwashing spell. He didn’t remember anything. The only thing that remained was the strong will that had lived in his head for a long time: I will kill Queen Magentano according to his wish.

Something definitely is going on here.

Who could have cast a powerful brainwashing spell on Sir Kyle when he was a sword master? What for? She didn’t have an answer despite the

countless investigations that were conducted. As though her head wasn’t aching with that alone, the east was going through turmoil.

Lloyd Frontera. His prediction was spot on.

The monster domino the sultan kingdom created in the east was much more substantial than she expected. The damage was considerably huge as 17 fiefdoms in the eastern range were annihilated.

Thwack! Fwish!

Another 50 bolts were fired while she was in a trance. And yet, despite the indiscriminate storm of arrows, her train of thought didn’t stop.

When I heard of his prediction, I thought it was just a potential disaster that could unfold. And I thought that its magnitude would be small enough for each fiefdom to adequately respond to. Who would have thought that it would be this destructive... This is clearly my fault.

She realized that she had thought too lightly of the incident.

Slash! Slash!

She wished that she could overcome this incident easily, like these bolts that sliced so smoothly in her hands.

“Your Majesty, Frontera barony has sent a response to your order.”

A clear voice echoed aloud in the corner of the training hall. The queen turned around to find an official hanging his head. She dropped her sword and wiped the sweat off her forehead.

“A response?” she said.

“Yes, Your Majesty. It has been sent through a carrier pigeon.”

“Bring it to me.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

She received the letter the palatial official held out and spread it out.

[I, your faithful subject Lloyd Frontera, express my sincere loyalty to Her Highness.]

She noticed that Lloyd's handwriting was ugly, as though he had scribbled it. The corners of her eyes drooped in annoyance.

Loyalty? I do not think so.

She knew that Lloyd would never be a loyal person. Raising her guard hard, she went on to read.

[Today, I have gravely received your order and vowed to obey it to the best of my abilities. However, I do not have the money to do so.]

"..."

She couldn't believe her eyes. She kept reading nonetheless.

[The state of the refugees flooding the fiefdom is wretched and sordid. The children are skins and bones, and the elderly have grown weak. They can only rise with the support of their children. In obedience to your dignified will, I yearn to feed them fully and clothe them warm. However, I do not have the money to do so.]

"Tsk."

She was starting to see where he was heading. She continued to read.

[It is my sincere wish to overcome this disaster wisely. However, I am poor. It is my desire to be loyal to your will. However, I do not have the money for it. I do not have any food, clothes, or other basic necessities either. If there is anything I have, it is the ebullient and yearning loyalty toward Your Highness, and with it, I can only cry out Your Majesty's name day and night toward the blinding and dark days ahead of me.]

"..."

Don’t do that please.

Queen Magentano sincerely wished to stop him, and she wanted to fold the letter and look at it no more. But Lloyd’s tenacious whining written in his letter was so appealing and forceful that she couldn’t pull her gaze away from it.

[Therefore, to overcome this wretched disaster as one, I have hung a painting of Your Majesty on my wall. Last night alone, I stood along with the starving refugees and gazed at your painting at length. Do you know what happened then? The boiling loyalty for Your Majesty wonderfully worked to erase the pang of hunger in the refugees!]

“...”

[The stinging pain of losing their home had the same effect. Just this morning, the refugees and I formed an organization called ‘XOXO Queen Magentano.’ Indeed, it is the organization, a fan club that strives to forget the pain of losing your home out of loyalty and affection toward Your Majesty.]

“...”

Hold on. What? Is he out of his mind?

[When a pang of hunger strikes, we gaze at Your Majesty’s painting. When pain rushes over us, we sing a song that celebrates Your Majesty. When the cold hits us, we count day and night how many days are left until your birthday. Once we do that, we smile in happiness in the clear hopes that our hunger, pain, and chills shall be forgotten.]

“...”

That sounds so sickening that it makes my hair stand.

[Certainly, it is not sickening. Every moment is fun. Every attempt feels anew. As I report to you, it dawned on me that being penniless has gifted the refugees and the fiefdom with happiness and enriched us with

meaningful experiences. We are happy because we are poor and hungry. We are joyful because we are poor and sick. We are thrilled because we are poor and cold.]

“...”

Stop it, you weirdo.

[What is the good of having money anyway? What else matters more than our loyalty to Your Majesty? That alone shall be enough to overcome this starvation, agony, and cold. So that when the spring comes to bloom beautiful flowers on the land, your beautiful name shall be written on our skulls. Oh, oh! Your Majesty! Ah! Your Majesty!]

“...”

She was out of things to say, so her resigned eyes simply moved to the far bottom of the letter.

[P.S.—Your Majesty is aware that there are only a handful of fiefdoms that remain intact in the Cremona region aside from us, and it is in my knowledge as well. Therefore, please remember me, who carried you on my back! Should Your Majesty still remember a part of the warmth in that devoted back of this menial servant, please give us some money... along with the royal master blacksmith Corgidus...]

“Ha, haha...”

Laughter escaped Queen Magentano after she finished reading the letter. She wasn’t even dumbfounded anymore.

I made another mistake.

Queen Magentano realized that she shouldn’t have sent the royal order to the Frontera barony at all. But she did, eventually giving Lloyd a reason to confidently whine about his predicament to her.

Tsk. I would have paid little attention to his whining if I did not issue the royal order.

It never occurred to her that Lloyd would whine and wail about his situation the moment he received the letter. And never with this kind of force and tenacity.

I should scale up my assistance to him more than what I had in mind.

Otherwise, Lloyd may whine again. No, it was just obvious that he would do so, and it would be even worse next time. Queen Magentano didn't wish to defile her eyes again as she read the letter once more. And so, she considered going all out in assisting him since she had meant to support him in the first place.

How about assigning the Frontera barony to act as the hub of rebuilding the Cremona region?

She recalled the news about the barony, about how it managed to defend monster invasions twice, and how it mastered a giant monster in the eastern range. Not enough with that, the orc tribe in the wilderness was persuaded to move to the range.

The Frontera barony must be the safest area from the monster domino situation now. If Lloyd's skills and my bountiful assistance are combined, then the reconstruction project is worth pushing ahead.

The reconstruction project could be expanded to make the Frontera barony become the second city in the Cremona region. If that happened...

Lloyd Frontera can be my shield in the east.

The barony was seeing a steep hike in population with the massive number of refugees flooding there. Stably housing the population and helping everyone settle there would allow the barony to quickly grow in size, taking the first step to becoming a big city.

That wouldn't be a loss for the palace and me as well.

If she showed him a clear benefit and let him enjoy it steadily. Lloyd was ready to give her his unchanging loyalty. The throne would grow stronger

as well if a person like him rose to power. The sultan's kingdom, her enemy in the east, would be deterred by his growing influence. So, all in all, it was a solid investment. Once that decision was made in her head, Queen Magentano looked up.

“This is my order. The palatial minister is thus ordered to return to the palace and hold a review committee on the motion of granting special escalation of status in the Frontera barony to the status of the county,” she ordered in a dignified voice”

***

“This isn’t an order but just a favor.”

Back here in the Frontera barony, the sun shone brightly in the early winter, and Lloyd started speaking on top of a plain lot.

“Have you ever run a hamster wheel before?”

“Ppodong?”

Ppodong cocked his round head to the side as he stood on Lloyd’s palm. Lloyd smiled in satisfaction.

“I guess you haven’t, right?”

“Ppodong!”

“I knew it. Do you want me to make one for you?”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“About 65 feet in diameter. You’ll be able to run to your heart’s content. How does that sound?”

“Ppodong!”

A joyous smile spread on Ppodong’s chubby cheeks from surprise. He found himself dancing his buttocks in happiness, and the same reaction was

visible on Lloyd's face, who smiled in contentment. But did Lloyd smile because he was happy to give a gift to Ppodong? Of course not.

Kekeke. The construction equipment has been acquired.

When Ppodong ran on the wheel in excitement, he would actually be turning the equipment connected to it.

That's how I'll make sure that the cement doesn't dry up!

The Frontera barony was welcoming the early winter, and the sun blessed the land. There, a special equipment called "Ready Mixed Concrete" was being invented to enable the construction of the first-ever apartment complex in the Lorasia continent. And that was the 65-foot diameter wheel Ppodong would turn with his utmost strength.

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Chapter 124: The Apartment Complex (1)

“My lord, it looks like we are almost there.”

The guard knight’s voice coming from outside woke the great palatial dwarf master, Wells Corgidus. He opened his wrinkled eyes, and his gaze darted outside the window to an unfamiliar scene. The Frontera barony, the destination of his journey.

This place is undeniably rural”

There were no decent buildings or anything similar. It was just a patch of fields amid a vast plain lot. However, Corgidus loved it.

At last, I can breathe in some fresh air.

It had been already 40 years since he started working in the palace as the craft master. How many times did he go out of the capital during those times?

Only a handful of times. And the last time I stepped out of the royal capital was 15 years ago”

Due to the years he spent residing in the capital, he was used to its high-rise buildings that stood compact with one another and bustling crowds that existed anywhere he went. And that was probably why he felt refreshed by this tranquil and unruffled landscape.

Well, though I didn’t come here for vacation.

Corgidus’s thoughts flew back to the event that happened a few days ago. It was late at night. The queen had called him to the palace, which was atypical of her. He had served three monarchs in his lifetime, so the relatively young queen treated him in a respectful manner. Thus, she never once called him into the palace past midnight. This was why Corgidus thought to himself that something special must have happened on his way to the palace.

And I was right.

The moment he paid his respects, the queen immediately asked something that caught him by surprise.

“What is the biggest object you have constructed so far?”

“It is the suspension bridge,” answered Corgidus, “we constructed last summer, Your Majesty.”

“Are you interested in constructing something far bigger than that?” asked Queen Magentano.

“Please do tell me what can be bigger than a suspension bridge.”

“A city for instance,” the queen stated.

“...”

Her suggestion to construct a city sounded like gibberish in his ears. Then, the queen went on to explain further”

Lloyd Frontera. That arrogant yet talented prick. She asked if I’m interested in working with him to build a new city.

Corgidus didn’t have to think about his answer. He immediately nodded, and for a simple reason. This offer served as a great opportunity to try something he had never done before and experiment with a new construction project. As such, he started to pack. 20 master blacksmiths working in the royal forge were selected. And at last, after a hectic 15-day journey with them, Corgidus arrived at this barony.

“Whew... My... My back aches so much,” Corgidus grumbled”

One of the young dwarf masters, who was seated across from Corgidus, grinned and spoke.

“Indeed. I never expected that we would be on such a rough journey without a single break.”

“Right? Sitting in a rattling carriage all day long is a hard job in itself,” Corgidus said.

His entire body felt sore and joints rattled in pain. He wondered if this was what delivery parcels went through during the several days it took to get delivered. But even when Corgidus arrived and hopped out of the carriage, rest was not granted to him.

“You are here. I have waited for you day and night.”

A voice welcomed Corgidus even before he could get out and get a breath of fresh air after being stuck in the carriage for so long. He wiggled his thick and bushy brow and turned to the voice, and when he checked who it was, he flew into a rage.

“Wait for me?” huffed Corgidus. “I don’t trust a single word you say, you prick.”

“Oh, is that so?”

“Of course.”

The voice belonged to Lloyd, who grinned as though he was here to escort Corgidus, but the latter scoffed and huffed through his nose at the young master.

“How can you come out alone if you have been waiting day and night, eh?” pointed Corgidus. “Be honest with me, you prick. You simply happened to spot us on your way somewhere else, am I wrong?”

“Woah,” said Lloyd, “since when did you learn to read minds?”

“Read minds, my butt. It is too obvious.”

“Haha. Had I known you’d react like this, I would have hung a welcome banner at the entrance of the fiefdom along with some flowers,” joked Loyd.

“Why, do you want me to die from embarrassment? Leave it,” Corgidus groped.

“And that is why I didn’t prepare anything. This is the beautiful thoughtfulness of humanity at work. Thoughtfulness.”

“Yeah, right. I’m so thankful that I’m tearing up.”

“You’re not alone. My eyes are also getting wet at finally meeting you,” Lloyd quipped.

“Really?”

“Yes. It’s not a lie. I’ve been waiting for you. So...”

Lloyd stopped and held out a wad of paper. Doubt flashed through Corgidus’s eyes.

“What is this?”

“You will find out once you see it.”

“...”

The 20-or-so pages of papers were rolled up, and Corgidus took and opened them up. His ears picked up the wily voice of Lloyd.

“While I was waiting for you day and night, I drew up some designs. Let’s be honest. We don’t have a use for banners or bouquets. I think these papers are better suited for you,” Lloyd said.

“Better suited for me? This?” Corgidus asked.

“Yes.”

“What makes you think so?”

“Your nose. It flared when you opened the paper.”

“...”

“Come on. I know you actually like them deep inside,” Lloyd insisted.

“...”

“Aren’t you honestly glad that I’m welcoming you with these blueprints?”

Lloyd’s voice grew more suggestive, and at last, Corgidus scoffed.

“Yeah, I like it, you prick. This is what I came to see. Happy now?”

“Yes. Look as much as you want.”

“Haha. But kid, what if I leave after I finish looking at these designs to my heart’s content? Where is your confidence coming from?” Corgidus asked.

“Um, isn’t this the first time you’re seeing anything like that blueprint?”

“What?”

“You’ll have trouble sleeping at night if you just leave after taking a peek,” Lloyd said with confidence.

“Me? Why?”

Corgidus spoke as his brows pulled upward. Lloyd brightly smiled.

“You will want to make it.”

“What is that...?”

“You will want to make it so much that those blueprints will appear in your dreams. Your desires will softly whisper into your heart... ‘Oh, oh, I want to make it! I want to tap the metal, ignite the fire, and fine tune it! I want to see the designs completed and operate in real life!’ Things like those.”

“What sort of nonsense are you spewing-”

“And every night, you will be tossing and turning in bed with regret, thinking about how you should have constructed the design on the blueprint and wishing to turn back time. Oh, how pitiful your blanket is. It’s going to be all bruised up but never have any time to heal,” Lloyd said.

“What? Why would I toss my blanket-”

“So,” Lloyd interrupted, “are you in or not?”

“...”

“It’s going to be super fun if you take the job. It’ll give you a strong purpose in life and plenty of impressive things to brag about later on. Are you sure you are not in?”

“Tsk. Fun, meaningful, and impressive, my foot. It’s either I do it, or not. There’s no need for your mumbo jumbo.”

“Does that mean you are in?” Lloyd said, his voice dripping with joy.

“Come on, you prick, I need to hear what this building is for before I go and make it,” muttered Corgidus.

Flip. Flip.

Flipping the blueprints quickly, Corgidus said, “Now, do explain them to me. What is this cylinder with one open side, and what’s that large container that leads from there? What on earth is this for?”

“Oh, that’s a mixer.”

“A mixer?”

“Yes, it’s to mix the cement,” Lloyd said as he nodded.

Everyone has seen a truck stirring and moving ready-mix concrete (remicon) in construction sites while going down a road. Specifically, the so-called mix truck with a round, slowly turning barrel attached on its end.

The vehicle was a key component in many constructions as it was used to build anything from small homes to large commercial structures.

“But this object appears familiar in my eyes. Why is that?” Corgidus asked.

“What do you mean that it’s familiar?”

“Isn’t this just an upsized treadwheel?”

“Yes, it is.”

“It is?” asked Corgidus.

“Yes. It will move using the power Ppodong generates as he runs.”

“...”

Corgidus was at a loss for words. Lloyd continued to explain.

“The concept is simple. Ppodong will run the treadwheel, and the power from it will be transferred following the axis, which will turn the body of the mixer.”

“Okay, but what are these spiral-shaped structures inside here?” asked Corgidus.

“Those are meant to continue stirring the cement and maintain its form.”

The mixer turned to prevent cement from hardening and getting mixed with rain and other unwanted particles in the batter. Moreover, it kept the quality of the cement consistent.

“There’s something called the ‘Brazil Nut Effect.’ And its goal is to prevent that,” Lloyd expounded.

“Brazil... Nut? What?” Corgidus asked, cocking his head to the side. It was his first time hearing the concept.

Lloyd grinned and went on, “It’s a real thing. To explain briefly, it refers to the phenomenon where small particles sink to the bottom when big and small particles are randomly mixed together.”

“Hmm. Small particles sink to the bottom, you said?”

“Yes.”

“Well, you have a point there. I have seen it happen quite a lot when I dealt with soot and sand.”

“You did, right?”

The Brazil Nut Effect. It was a phenomenon proven by science. Anyone could check this by throwing thick beans and small rice into a bottle and shaking it up. Otherwise, they could use small Lego blocks and a box. Unlike how most people expected the large particles to sink to the bottom, it was the opposite. They sat on the top.

Well, but there’s a counter effect depending on the conditions.

Anyway, this Brazil Nut Effect was to be watched out for when mixing and depositing cement. The cement had to be kept under watch even after it was mixed. Otherwise, large particles in cement would float up, sinking the smaller ones to the bottom. And when this type of cement was used to construct a building, it brought about a disaster.

Cement cannot harden when its quality is not consistent. Sometime later, the building will crack, break, tumble, and crumble to dust.

Such an event was to be prevented come hell or high water. It was especially so for this construction.

This apartment complex is different from the structure I’d built underwater in Cremo. And it’s also different from the bridge tower I’d constructed back in the capital. Pouring fresh cement as soon as it’s made is an absolute no in this project.

Lloyd recalled the construction projects where he used cement. The artificial ground in Cremo and the basic structure of the bridge tower in the capital were different from this project. The previous structures were gigantic but simple. All Lloyd needed to do was pour cement by loads into the empty frame. That was why he was able to pour and pour the cement as soon as it was made. But now...

The conditions are different.

The apartment complex he would be working from now on had a more complex structure. The floors, walls, ceilings, and stairs inside had to be taken into account separately. The intricate and elaborate structures were weaved one another, so their formworks had to be equally small and elaborate. Lloyd could no longer mindlessly pour cement into a formwork as he did in previous jobs.

If I do that, the cement won't properly cover all the corners. There will be unfilled cracks and bubbles in cement. That would be troubling.

In actual construction sites, the task of depositing concrete fell on the shoulders of the most skilled workers. It was an elaborate and detailed job that required dexterity and skill.

That's why the job takes a long time. But what happens when cement is deposited without a mixer? The whole thing will harden and be divided into components even before one can start depositing. That's why we need the mixer.

The mixer was meant to mix the concrete well and keep it consistent. As such, the equipment was indispensable to the apartment complex construction.

"Oh, and this one is the pump for pouring cement," Lloyd said.

"A pump?"

"Yes."

Lloyd pointed at the other blueprint.

“Connected to the mixer, it will pull up the cement. Since we’ll be building a high-rise building, the pump will suck the cement all the way to the top.”

“Hmm. Did you get the idea from the screw-type pump used in waterwheels?” asked Corgidus.

“Yes. That’s precisely correct. I’m thinking of manufacturing a human-powered pump.”

“Perfect. That doesn’t seem too complicated,” Corgidus complimented.

“So can you make them for us?”

“Ha. Are you doubting my ability?” huffed Corgidus.

“Of course, not. How would I dare to,” Lloyd smiled greasily”

This caused Corgidus to frown.

“Tsk.”

Every conversation he had with this prick was the same. He talked to him, and before he knew it, he was already on board with his plan.

“My goodness. Come to think of it now, you expected me to be here and drew a blueprint in advance. It seems like I’m always the one who’s losing out. You’re so cunning as if a big serpent lives in your still-developing brain.”

“I appreciate the compliment.”

“Cunning and brazen.”

“So, Master Corgidus,” Lloyd said, “how long do you think the manufacturing will take?”

“Tsk. I shall let you know after I make one. Show me our studio first.”

“Of course.” Lloyd then led the way quickly.

Ten more days passed, and indeed, the skills of a royal master were on another level. And besides, the Great Master Corgidus was the one leading the project, and Bangul’s best steel dungs, which Lloyd had regularly made sure to collect, were being used. These three elements compounded to bring about the best possible result. On top of that, the treadwheel was 65 feet in diameter, and the size of the axis and mixer body connected to it was considerable as well. The sheer size of the large structure was something impossible for the blacksmiths here in this fiefdom. But to Corgidus and his team, the job only took ten days. And it operated extremely well.

“Ppodong!”

Vrrr... Ppodong got on the treadwheel after eating the red sunflower seed. The 65-foot treadwheel started to heave.

“Ppodong?”

A large smile appeared on Ppodong’s face. He was running on a treadwheel for the first time in his life. It was more fun than he had expected. Thanks to his enjoyment, Ppodong’s speed gradually increased, and the rotation of the treadwheel grew more violent.

Rattle! Rattle! Rattle!

The 65-foot treadwheel rotated with Ppodong’s power alone. This ferocious rotation power coursed through the axis and to the mixer.

Fwish!

The mixer rotated heavily, and the cement in it danced and fluctuated. At the same time, Lloyd’s hope increased along with it.

Jackpot. It’s working perfectly.

Thanks to the dwarf masters the queen had dispatched, the key construction equipment was finished. Now, it was time to kickstart and construct the apartment complex.

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Chapter 125: The Apartment Complex (2)

The apartment complex. It was the most popular form of residency chosen by South Koreans along with the walk-up. But here in the Lorasian continent, it was a new type of structure that was being built for the first time in history, and its construction had officially begun.

“The construction, like always, begins with the foundation.”

Lloyd gazed at the vast plain lot that stretched in front of him. This land was located in the northern part of the barony and stood opposite of the Prona River that hugged the entire fiefdom clockwise. Lloyd had this part of the land in plan when he decided to build the apartment complex.

This place sits distant from the center of the fiefdom, and the land isn’t rich enough to be used as a field.

The land wasn’t used for anything in the first place, so it was the perfect spot for construction which meant that Lloyd didn’t have to compensate for any damage or loss to the land.

“So, let’s dig the land first. Javier?”

“Yes. Did you call me?”

“Of course, I did. Who else is here besides you and me?” huffed Lloyd.

“...”

“Hmm?” Lloyd studied Javier’s face. “What’s wrong? You look like you saw a ghost,” said Lloyd.

“May I be frank?”

“Yeah, go ahead.”

“I don’t want to do it,” Javier said.

“What?”

“I don’t want to do it, I said.”

Javier turned to his side, and his eyes flashed with grouchiness, so spiky and sharp like a porcupine’s quills.

“I know what you will entrust me with. The mana blast presumably. And you’re going to mark the ground with your red-dyed brush, telling me to vertically blast a hole wherever you see appropriate,” Javier said defiantly.

“Yeah, so?”

“And you will pour cement into the dozens of holes I’ll bore.”

“Yeah, so?”

“And you will use the cement chunks as poles that will become the foundation of the building,” Javier drawled.

“Yes, that’s correct. Hey, you’re kind of smart.”

“Thank you... No, that’s not what I’m getting at. I’m saying that I don’t want to do it,” Javier objected.

“Are you saying you don’t want to dig holes into the ground?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because I think you only regard me as a convenient tool, and nothing more,” Javier bemoaned, and his voice turned cold. “To remind you, Master Lloyd, of something you seem to be forgetting right now, I am a knight who vowed his allegiance to the lord.”

“Yes, yes. So?”

“And yet, you put me to work as though it is only natural that I do these things. As if my duty is to be mobilized into all sorts of constructions, not protect the fiefdom, which is my actual calling.”

“Yes, yes. But you’re going to do it anyway, aren’t you?”

“...”

“Of course, I get that you hate doing it, but you will do it, right? After all, this is for the development of the fiefdom,” Lloyd said.

“Even still, I wanted to voice my thoughts out.”

“Aha. My little Javier, you wanted to throw a tantrum in front of your big brother, didn’t you?”

“...”

“But do you think I give two hoots about it?” joked Lloyd as he sneered.

“...”

“Now, let’s get to work. Work, I say.”

Lloyd chuckled as he held up a jar, which contained red dye he would be using to mark the ground. Lloyd stabbed the land with the brush, and he went on to explain to Javier.

“Here. And here. And here. 39 feet deep. And as for the diameter, set it to 20 inches. As you can see, the distance is 9.8 feet.”

“Is that my task?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, can you finish it before lunchtime?”

“To do so, I will have to overwork my body.”

“And that is why it’s a job,” said Lloyd.

“Excuse me?” Javier grumbled at the prospect of the hard work given to him. Lloyd gazed at him pitifully.

“You asked just now whether this was your task,” Lloyd said.

“Yes, I did.”

“Don’t you know what it stands for?”

“I do not know.”

“Fine, then I’ll tell you. It’s been a while since I told someone about this. Can you spell the letter one by one, please?” asked Lloyd.

“What are you-”

“Come on.”

“J...”

“Just.”

“O...”

“Overwork till death.”

“B...”

“But never complain. Look at your face. You didn’t know? It’s just the way of this world.”

“...”

Javier scowled in annoyance while Lloyd smiled in satisfaction.

“Good luck to you. I’m off to prepare the cement.”

Whoosh. Javier was given no time to fight back. Lloyd simply left after finishing what he had to say.

“...”

Wow. Young master, I wish to send you on a one-way trip to the underworld.

“Tsk.” Jaiver then resigned to get to work and plucked his sword. And there, the great construction of the apartment complex took place.

***

Time sped by like lightning. The construction progressed smoothly during this period. The monumental apartment complex, building 101, boasted a basic foundation that was 492 feet in width and length and 22,500 square meters in area. But of course, the building wasn’t set to take up the whole land. It was shaped like a square. Thanks to it, the basic foundation took place surrounding the plaza.

Kaboom! Crash!

The diameter was 1.6 feet, and the depth was 39 feet. Each hole stood about 3 yards apart. Once each hole was bored, Lloyd poured freshly produced cement. More than 3,000 cement pillars were erected in the ground about 10,000 square meters in mass. The next part of the project was the groundwork. On top of the 3,000 pillars, a formwork as high as about 2 feet was erected.

“But, of course, there’s more to it than just pouring cement. The important part starts from here on out.”

Around the time the formwork was completed, Lloyd gathered 120 orc miners.

“So everyone,” Lloyd said, “today, we’ll be playing the steel bar folding game to our amusement.”

“Oink?! Folding steel bars, oink?”

“Yes, that’s right. Here, do you see this?”

“Yes, I do, oink.”

Lloyd held up the steel bar made by Bangul. The orc miner representative Arosh cocked his head to the side.

Folding that is a game? Oink?

Arosh wondered what the point of it was. Where's the fun in that? He asked himself. Meanwhile, Lloyd went on to demonstrate.

"Like this. This way, ugh. Like this! Whew, you play by folding it up like this."

Creak! Crack! Creak!

Lloyd rotated his mana circle to the full and transferred the amplified mana power into his grip. The steel bar, which was as thick as his fingers, bent by 90 degrees. Another was bent again in his fingers. Then, they were tied together. By doing so, Lloyd demonstrated the basic steel bar-tying method in front of everyone.

"What now? Did you get a good look?" asked Lloyd.

"Yes, I did! But I have a question, oink!"

"Arosh? Yes, tell me. What is it that you want to know?"

"What's the benefit of folding up the bars, oink?"

"Aha."

A sly smile formed on Lloyd's face that was marked with satisfaction, and he gave a clear answer.

"It's great for muscle development."

"M-muscles, oink?"

"Yeah. It's super good for your grip power, wrist, and forearm. The best. It's really the best," Lloyd assured.

“F-forearm, oink!”

“Yes, yes. The forearms and arms. This game will make your arms bulge with rugged muscles, even more so than now. And make worm-like veins appear from your wrist to elbow just from pinching your finger… It’s amazing. How do you like that?”

“V-veins, oink!!”

“Thrilling, isn’t it? The harder you play, the veinier you will become.”

“Is it true? Even more than doing a wrist curl? Is it more effective than wrist curls, oink?”

“Oh, please, wrist curl is just a warm-up exercise compared to this.”

“G-great! We will learn! Now! Folding game, oink!!”

“Oiiink!!!”

120 orc miners breathed heavily through their noses in sheer excitement. Just like that, Lloyd procured primitive steel workers who didn’t need any tools. Their training was simple. The orcs didn’t need much training since they were strong. Just giving a couple of tips was enough for them to be familiarized with the process. This whole thing was possible because of a natural tool that moved lighter than most professional tools: their fingers.

The steel bars were assembled at supersonic speed to cover the foundation and the first floor. At the same time, the formwork gradually expanded in size without an inch amiss in accordance with Lloyd’s design. And the cement depositing took place.

“Ppodong! Turn it!”

“Ppodong!”

Fwoosh! The 65-foot treadwheel rotated in a frenzy, and the colossal mixer connected to the wheel turned accordingly. The various materials loaded

there mixed in a flash, but it wasn’t done in a random manner. Even the proportion of the mix followed Lloyd’s meticulous calculations.

Several factors were taken into account. These included the specified compressive strength, the target strength, the slump and AE air amount, as well as the proportion of the water and bonding materials, and of the fine aggregate and compression strength. These elements were mixed in perfect ratio, and the batter was mixed using Ppodong’s strength. Afterward, it was pulled up through the screw-type manual pump manufactured by the master dwarf.

“One, two. Press!”

“Argh!!!”

Clack! Clack! Clack!

It took 20 White Cavalry lancers to grab the pump knob. All drenched in sweat, they pressed, pulled, and pressed the knob again, allowing the pump to turn with force and suck the cement from the mixer. The cement then flowed out through the elongated leather hose. Its end was grabbed by Lloyd, who personally oversaw the construction site.

“Continue! Keep the momentum!” Lloyd yelled.

Splash! Splash!

A line of cement came out of the nose as they pumped, perfectly filling up the complex and intricate formwork. Meanwhile, Lloyd activated the optional survey skill Subterranean Scanning and observed the formwork in real-time.

Okay. It’s filling up nicely.

Lloyd saw that the cement was nicely filling up into all the empty crevices. Air bubbles were prone to appear in the corners of the formwork and steel bar links when the depositing job took place in a hurry. But thankfully, the cement was filling up without missing a single spot.

The cement mix is a success.

It wasn't too thick or watery. It couldn't be any better than this. The pump functioned, much to Lloyd's satisfaction. To his relief, the first depositing job ended in a brilliant success.

"Great. Now, it needs to be cured for three days," Lloyd said.

"By curing, you mean to let it dry and harden, right?"

"Wow! My Javier, how far you have come!"

"Like I had any other choice... It was because of you, Master Lloyd... Anyway..."

Javier, whose cheeks were smudged with dirt, opened his eyes wide.

"Can we rest for three days while this one is cured?" asked Javier.

"No."

"..."

"Rest? For what? We have other work to do."

"But you said that we have three days until it cures-"

"But we can construct the foundation of Building 102 while that cures, don't you think?" Lloyd said matter-of-factly.

"..."

"Come on," Lloyd said, "You weren't planning to goof around, were you? Are you serious?"

"That is-"

"Can't you hear the devastated cries of the refugees living in those makeshift tents?"

“...”

“Haa... You let me down. I wanted to construct this apartment as soon as possible even if it meant working overnight. That way, we can relieve the refugees’ pain sooner.”

“...”

“Haa... This is unfortunate. I wanted to provide them with a home soon even if it meant skipping dinner. That way, we can see happy smiles appear on their faces.”

“...”

Ugh, this young master is just...

Javier gave in at last.

“Ha... I see. So blast the ground just like I did before?” Javier asked in resignation.

“Yeah, shall we head there right now?”

“Yes...”

Javier, now resigned once more, had to draw his sword one more time. The great apartment construction continued once again.

***

A similar construction continued from that point on.

“Steel bars! We fold, oink!”

“Steel bars! We bent, oink!”

“Lunch box! We eat, oink!”

“It sure looks tasty, oink!”

The orcs bent the metal bars and tied them together with vivacity. The carpenter, on the other hand, built up the formworks. The entire process was similar to the one for the first floor, and it was like they were pressing Ctrl+c/Ctrl+v.

That's the good thing about constructing apartments!

Every story held the same structure as the others. So, it wasn't an overstatement to say that the process was just simply copying and pasting the same thing again and again. Things became much easier and faster after the first floor. The process could just be repeated from there.

And naturally, the workers learn the ropes and get better by many folds.

Thanks to the repeated course of action, their efficiency multiplied with each passing day. When they deposited the cement for the second floor of Building 101 and cured it, they proceeded to work on Building 102. When the cement for the first floor of Building 102 was being cured, they worked to build the formwork and steel bars of the third floor of Building 101. The whole process was smooth and perfect, reminding Lloyd of the rotation of the perfectly fit cogwheels. The fiefdom was struck with good luck in the process. The supplies the queen had sent arrived at last.

"According to Her Majesty, the supply will arrive once every month for the time being."

It was the words of the officer that brought them here. Thankfully, the food situation for the refugees was now better. Meanwhile, the floors of Building 101 and 102 gradually increased. Now, Lloyd summoned another assistant he had in mind.

"Okay, now, Bibeong! Lift it up!"

"Bibeong!"

A special mercenary was hired: Bibeong, the conqueror of Lake Kapua. Biebong's massive body and power allowed various materials to be transferred from the ground to the highest floor. In other words, he acted as

a tower crane, which was commonly used in modern construction sites. Bibeong helped the construction to add more momentum. Cement was poured on the fifth floor. Steel bars and formwork were finished for the sixth floor. Pour, plan, pour, tap, and refine. One month later, Building 101 became an eight-story building.

“But don’t think it’s over yet!” Lloyd shouted. “Tell me! What’s the most important part of construction?!”

“The finish and detail!”

The engineering corp answered in unison when Lloyd shouted a question. And just like that, as the snow started to fall in the Frontera fiefdom, the outlines of the monumental and lucrative apartment complex that would drastically advance the fiefdom started to take shape.

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Chapter 126: How to Acquire Insulation (1)

Thwack! Tap!

The first snow of the year was falling, and the cold wind blew. But the snowfall and gust weren't enough to dampen and freeze the passion of the workers in the construction field.

"Woah! It's snowing!"

"Eh? It's really snowing!"

"Wahaha! Looks like this is our lucky day!"

As the soft hail started to fall to announce the first snowfall, a cheer erupted among the engineers. The reason was simple.

"Compensation for inclement weather!"

These engineers belonged to the fiefdom, so they were the soldiers hired by the lord. Therefore, even if they participated in the construction, the only additional payment they could receive from the lord was some occasional bonuses and nothing more. However, there were some exceptions. It was when the construction took place after dusk late at night or during inclement weather. On top of that, when the job involved some form of risk, they received a thick wad of bonuses. Such a type of compensation system was put up by Lloyd, who meticulously supervised the construction site.

Master Lloyd is somewhat, no, shamelessly a cheapskate. He despises losing even a single coin. But what really amazes me is how thoroughly he takes care of his workers.

Everyone was weirded out by this. On a normal day, Lloyd was the worst miser. A loss of coin or peanuts was enough to prompt him to kick his blanket at night in frustration. Being such a terrible pinchpenny, everyone wanted to know whether it was a trait ingrained in the young master's genes. Upon hearing this quality of his, an outsider may think that Lloyd

was the worst boss to work for. That, too, was the concern for the engineers at first. But it turned out, he was different. It was the opposite.

He took great care of us.

When it came to special bonuses, Lloyd was meticulous about giving the proper amount. There was never a delay of payment as well. He met the payment deadline on the dot. Lloyd even gave the workers holidays. One rest day every week. And he emphasized that the construction site should be kept organized and tidy as messy construction sites were prone to safety accidents. And so, the engineers came to have firm trust that Master Lloyd never considered them as replaceable goods and that he sincerely cherished them. The same was today.

“Hey, you! Make sure you mark the time the snow fell!” shouted Lloyd”

“Why?” said the youngest engineer in the corp.

“Are you serious? Because the rule is to work for an hour and take 20 minutes of rest by the fire during snowy days,” said Lloyd”

“Oh, do you mean the rule Master Lloyd has set here on the construction site?”

“Yep, that’s the one.”

Thwack! Thud!

The engineers got to work with more zeal, waiting for the promised inclement-weather bonus and rest.

“By the way, I have a question I want to ask,” said the same young boy.

“Hmm? What is it?” answered one of the commanders beside him.

“It’s about this central heating room we are constructing.”

“Uh-huh.”

“Why are we constructing today?”

“What? What are you saying?”

“I had heard that the refugees can only live in the apartment complex next fall. That means that there is still a lot of time left... So why hurry the job when it’s snowing?” asked the boy.

“My, my. Are you saying that Master Lloyd may be wasting his money by unnecessarily putting us to work during severe weather conditions?” answered his senior.

“Yes. Master Lloyd may be taking good care of us but he never is wasteful. So I can’t understand even a little why he is pushing ahead with the job today.”

“Tsk. How could you be so narrow-minded?”

“Excuse me...?”

The commander clucked his tongue.

“What are we constructing today?”

“I heard we are building a heating facility,” answered the young soldier as he gulped.

“And what season are we in now?”

“Winter.”

“Then,” said the commander, “should we not hurry to finish constructing the facility before winter has passed?”

“But, they will be coming in next fall-”

“Exactly. That’s why we need to finish up the heating facility and test it out,” enlightened the commander.

“Oh...” he gasped.

“So before they come live here next autumn, we should make sure that the heating facility is running smoothly to heat up indoors in the next winter. We need to check those things. Okay?”

“Th-that’s why...”

“Indeed. That’s why. Don’t forget that Master Lloyd is a meticulous man. So, let’s get to work now.”

“Yes!”

The inclement weather bonus was set to be paid, and the engineers were able to work hard in anticipation of the pay. Thanks to that, the heating facility was built in a smooth manner without any interruptions. First, the central heating room for Building 101 was built in a corner of the plaza. Then, a steam kiln specially made by the dwarf master was installed, and bamboo pipes were added to transfer the steam from the kiln. Next, the exterior of the pipes was wrapped with an insulator made of wheat straw, chaff, and lime. Afterward, those numerous pipes were intricately connected to each household like a spiderweb before they were connected to a steam grill that was likened to a modern radiator.

Of course, that won’t be as effective as ondols in heating up the floor.

Even if that was the case, however, the structure of the apartment complex promised less heat loss than residential houses. That is, the building required less heating. What was more, each unit was much smaller than the average house.

It’s small because there is no kitchen or dining room.

The bathroom and toilets and whatnot were designed to be installed in a communal facility. So each household only held a small living room and bedroom. It was Lloyd’s desperate measure to accommodate as many refugees as possible and minimize the burden of heating.

But still... I must make sure that the heating works properly.

This central steam-type heating for each building was something Lloyd was trying out for the first time. When he ran a simulation using his optional skill, there weren't any serious malfunctions. Even so, Lloyd didn't put his guard down as the construction took place. He checked the facility every day without fail, personally overseeing the insulation construction indoors. The walls and floors were thoroughly plastered with insulation mixed with wheat straw, chaff, and lime. Once they dried up enough, they were finished with thin wooden planks. And at last, the construction of the heating system for Building 101 was completed toward the end of the year. Lloyd immediately went on to test the function right away.

Please! Heat up!

Fwish!

The steam kiln for Building 101 was warmed by the heat of the coals. Boiled water and hot steam flowed through the pipes.

Great. It's working well so far.

To Lloyd's relief, the steam wasn't leaking from the pipes. He walked following the pipes and entered the first floor. He touched the radiator of each household.

"It's hot!"

Lloyd almost burned his hand. A smile escaped from him.

Good. Now to the second floor.

After looking around the entire units on the first floor, Lloyd checked the second floor. It was equally hot. But as he went up, things became different.

Hmm...? It's a bit...

The look on Lloyd's face slightly hardened as he inspected the fourth floor.

Though it’s very minimal, it’s getting colder as I go up.

The first floor was scorching hot. The second floor was hot. The third floor was warm. But now on the fourth floor...

It’s slightly lukewarm. I’m sure of it.

Nervousness gripped Lloyd at that moment. And when he came up to the fifth floor, it was more lukewarm than the fourth floor. The sixth and seventh floors were chilly. And when he got to the eighth floor, it was cold.

Woah. Is this for real? This is bad.

As a pang of disappointment continued to grip him, Lloyd analyzed the reason. It was actually simple.

The actual insulation of the pipes is doing more poorly than my simulation. That’s why the heat is lost when the steam flows through the pipes.

The proof was the hot lower floors, which were closer to the heating room. And it got colder the farther he climbed.

“It’s because of the long pipes. Even though I separated the pipes for each household to prevent heat loss, the distance from the upper floors to the heating room is just too far. The insulation isn’t enough. That’s the main reason.”

Tap. Tap. Lloyd concluded as he tapped the pipes of the eighth floor that had gone cold.

“Is there a way we can shorten the pipes?” asked Javier as he furrowed his brow.

“Of course, we can.” Lloyd chuckled. “The solution is actually simple. Just put a heating room for every floor.”

“But why can’t we do that?”

“The reason is just as simple. It’s dangerous.”

“Dangerous? Why?”

“Fire.”

There was finality in Lloyd’s voice.

“Hundreds of refugees,” went on Lloyd, “will be living here in Building 101. And if a fire breaks out in one of the heating rooms that I install on every floor, a catastrophe too terrible to put into words will occur.”

“There will be a great number of casualties...”

“Yes, exactly,” agreed Lloyd. “I built this building to house as many people as possible. The priority wasn’t comfort. And the design followed that direction. The interior is entirely made of wood. So if a fire breaks out, at least half of them will be scorched to death, unable to flee.”

Lloyd wasn’t joking. He was dead serious about it. One fire, and it was sure to spell a massive disaster. At least hundreds of casualties would be seen. Lloyd could ascertain so because he had designed the building himself.

There aren’t any modern-type escape facilities or fire extinguishing facilities here.

This world didn’t have fire extinguishers. No ventilators to send the smoke outside. No helicopter to rescue people who fled to the roof.

“If there’s one, Hamang is our best asset as he can spit a large amount of water at once. But what if Hamang isn’t there? What if he’s vacant? Then there is no other solution. If we’re unlucky, a catastrophe no one can deal with may break out. Besides, even if he’s here, he won’t be able to kill the fire in one gush. And that was the reason why I designed the heating room and cooking area to be placed outside,” explained Lloyd.

“Was it the reason why you wanted to replace the interior lights with light bugs as well?”

“Yeah, obviously. They are common in the eastern range and safe.”

“For safety reasons, I see. Hmm, to wrap up, we should keep the heating facility in the courtyard but improve the insulation of the pipes.”

“That’s exactly right. Javier, man, you’ve gotten smarter these days.”

“Smarter? I doubt it.”

“You do?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“After all, I was already smart in the first place.”

Lloyd didn’t say anything. He simply stared at Javier with a dumbfounded look on his face.

“Ehem,” coughed Javier, “I was being serious.”

“Normally, people say that they were joking.”

“What is the need for it? I am telling the truth.”

“Look at you. You’re just shamelessly saying it’s the truth now.”

“I am a knight, after all,” said Javier.

“What does that have anything to do with that?”

“I learned that knights are always to speak the truth. For example, Javier Asrahan is smart. Javier Asrahan is handsome. Javier Asrahan possesses a noble character. And so on.”

Lloyd was speechless.

“There are other truths besides those. For example, Lloyd Frontera is single. And so, he is jealous of Javier Asrahan’s competence, handsomeness, and

character out of his stingy, narrow-minded, and small-hearted qualities. And these are some of the uncomfortable truths.”

“Hey,” Lloyd called.

“Yes?”

“Having fun?”

“I am for the first time in a while.”

“Tsk.”

“Anyway,” Javier said as he changed the subject. “How can we improve the insulation of the pipes?”

“I don’t know. That’s a pickle for me as well.”

Lloyd scratched the back of his neck for this was really a concern.

“Actually, the batter made out of the wheat straw, chaff, and lime was the best insulator I had in mind.”

It was true. The wheat straw, chaff, and lime were the easiest materials to acquire around here in large volumes. This meant that they were low in price as well. The cost was a very important factor to take into account.

Duh. I need to insulate the whole building in the future as well. So if the materials are hard to come by and expensive, it just doesn’t cut it.

But other than the soaring material cost, what equally mattered was their availability. A low supply could affect the construction schedule. And that was why Lloyd decided to go for the wheat straw, chaff, and lime as the main materials. They were cheap and common. He ran countless experiments to come up with the best combination that ensured great performance.

And yet, the insulation isn’t enough.

Lloyd started to deliberate what more he must do with the insulation to keep the heat in the pipes.

The pipes were designed to be as little exposed as possible. There is nothing more to do with the design. This means that I must look further into the material.

He needed materials that provided better insulation than the initial formula but was cheap and easily available. Lloyd put on his thinking cap to figure out if there is any material that satisfies these conditions. His deliberation lasted for three straight days. For a second, it crossed his mind to use CP for the Ending Spoiler to find the answer to the solution. But he shook his head.

No. I should save it for when I'm more desperate or when I really can't find a solution.

CP was way harder to save than RP which was based on likeability. As such, it was wasteful to spend the point just because he met a small hurdle. Two more days were spent pondering the problem. Lloyd rummaged through his memories and records during those days.

At a time like this, this method may help.

Lloyd brought out a bundle of papers from his bedroom drawer. These were the notes that he consistently recorded from the moment he came to this world. They were related to the novel, *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

For people's memories aren't perfect.

Lloyd knew that he wasn't perfect as well. He wasn't a genius. That was why he recorded the notes with fervor. The plot, major characters, accidents, setting, and other small facts of the novel were jotted down in detail every time he remembered them.

I think I read about a setting that can help my situation right now... What was it...? Eh? Hold on.

After a long time of rifling through his records, Lloyd's gaze stopped at one note.

Found it. This is it.

The records he finally found had the following writings: "Elves' woods," "Javier's love," and "Warm dragon breath."

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Chapter 127: How to Acquire Insulation (2)

There were people everywhere. And every one of them was ragged.

“...”

The sun was setting earlier than usual now, and Javier threw his gaze down below the hill. The plain lot that used to be empty and bare was now jam-packed with people. Countless tenets stood close to one another, and people moved through the tents. They were the refugees that recently arrived at the Frontera fiefdom.

“Sir Asrahan, the food rations are ready.”

“...”

Javier turned and found a high-rank guard officer. He faintly nodded his head.

“Let us begin before the sun sets.”

“Yes, sir.”

Javier went down the hill with the soldier, dozens of large pots hanging here and there. The scent of food wafted out from there, and refugees queued up in a long line. Their eyes reflected their hunger and desperation.

“Start the distribution.”

“Yes, sir.”

The food trays were filled in order, and the long line started to shorten. One after another, every refuge was asked a question by Javier.

“Are you sick or feeling discomfort of any sort?” asked Javier.

Most of them said they were fine. At times, some said they were sick, and Javier ran a thorough check on their state, recording their name, symptom,

and makeshift tent number.

“I see. A physician will be here later tonight to check up on you. Until then, make sure to eat and rest,” advised Javier.

“My... Thank you... You are an honored knight, and yet you take care of this old lady...”

“Not at all. I am just doing what is right.”

Javier counted the number of patients and oversaw the distribution, spending many sleepless hours at night.

“But, sir, are you not going to eat?” asked one of the soldiers.

“Later.”

There was the tidying-up left after the distribution. The soldiers said that they could take it from here, but Javier remained and worked with them. It was because Javier considered it his job as he was the supervisor. But when he was distributing dinner, something took place.

“...”

Among the refuge tents that lined up in strings, Javier spotted a kid wandering around. He appeared to be seven or eight. But something was off about his gait and movement. With a food tray in his hand, the boy peeked into the tents and glanced around without rest. He walked quickly around the area as if he was lost.

Did he forget the way to his tent?

It appeared so since there were dozens of large tents around. Minus the number marked on the tent door, every single one of them looked the same. Even an adult would be confused by it.

“Kid.”

Javier walked over to the kid and called him. The flustered boy looked up. Javier strove to put on a warm smile on his face.

“Are you lost?”

“...”

The boy nodded, his eyes all wet. Javier carefully stroked the boy’s head.

“I think I can help you with that. Why don’t you let me help find your tent?” suggested Javier.

“...”

The boy nodded again.

“But why didn’t you eat the food? It’s going to get cold. Are you not hungry?”

“I am... hungry,” the boy finally said.

But what he said next caught Javier by surprise.

“But I won’t eat it,” said the boy.

“Why not?”

“My mother is hungrier.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes.”

“...”

Javier wondered why this kid came out to take the food when he had a mother. There must be a reason, he thought to himself. He held out his hand.

“I will hold the tray for you.”

“...”

“I won’t spill it. I promise.”

“Okay...”

Javier took the tray and wrapped the boy with his other hand. And then he called some of the soldiers cleaning the place and the representatives among the refugees. After some searching and asking, Javier finally managed to find the boy’s tent and discovered why he came out to collect the food ration all alone.

“Allen?”

When Javier stepped in, he heard a woman’s voice. Her voice rang clear and aloud among the many refugees in the tent. The same thing was the case for this boy, whose name seemed to be Allen.

“Mom!”

The boy sprinted into his mother’s embrace. But something about her gaze was off.

Her eyes aren’t focused. She can’t see.

She was visually impaired. But it appeared that she was not used to the discomfort she was experiencing. All of her body gestures and movements looked awkward. And Javier noticed why instantly.

She wasn’t born like this. She recently lost her vision.

Javier’s face turned wistful. He postulated that the monsters took her vision but managed to get here after exerting every bit of strength in saving her child. And now, the boy was the one taking care of his mother by receiving the food for her. Taking care of his mother was more important than filling up his stomach. Javier felt his throat getting hot, and he got on one knee and carefully put the food tray down. The food was cold.

“Here.”

Javier’s voice and presence made the mother flinch, so he said, “Do not be afraid. I am Javier Asrahan, currently supervising the guards. I came here with the boy as he was lost.”

“I-is that really true?”

“Yes. And I brought your dinner with the boy,” assured Javier.

“How can I repay you for your kindness...”

“Please do not mention it. I will help you. Here, slowly.”

Javier lifted the spoon. But was it out of compassion? Perhaps so. Or maybe it was the blouse that was smudged with porridge. Or maybe, it was because he was suddenly reminded of his childhood.

“Now, open your mouth please,” cooed Javier.

“How can I dare...”

“It is fine. There is plenty of food. Even for the child.”

“Oh...”

His assurance that there was enough food for the child brought relief to her face. Javier slowly began to feed her. The first spoon full of food. The second spoon full of nostalgia. Once he was done, Javier spoke to the child.

“Kid. Do you see the mark at the entrance?” asked Javier.

“Yes, I see it.”

“This is A-3.”

“A-3...”

“Remember that, and you can come into that tent starting tomorrow. Do you think you can do it?”

“Yes! I can.”

“Good boy.”

As Javier stroked the child’s head, he wished that Master Lloyd would come up with something to solve the insulation issue since this was as far as he could help the people out. If Master Lloyd succeeded, this mother and child and so many others could live more comfortably. And perhaps because of that sentimentality, that night, Javier committed the mistake of nodding his head when Lloyd, who finally found the solution, asked for his help.

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“So, you are telling me that you will go into the Everglow Woods where the elves live and acquire the sap of the Elensia Tree?”

“Yeah,” answered Lloyd.

“But that is just outrageous...”

Javier shook his head. He threw a determined gaze at Lloyd, who came to the former’s room to sing a lullaby.

“I can’t help you with that,” defied Javier.

“Wow. Why?”

“What do you mean why? Simply because it is impossible.”

“But you just nodded that you will help me out a second ago,” objected Lloyd.

“You did not mention then that you are planning to go to the Everglow Woods.”

“Aha. You said you’d help out when you thought it was easy, but now that it’s not, you’re taking back what you said and backing out?”

“That is not what I mean-”

“Cut the crap. You know I’m right,” said Lloyd.

“...”

“Since when did you like to break your promise?”

“...”

“Why? Am I wrong?”

“...”

Javier pressed his lips together, saying not a word. He knew that Master Lloyd was right.

“But, Master Lloyd…”

“Yeah, go defend yourself.”

“What you’re trying is impossible.”

“What? Extracting Elensia sap from wood?”

“Yes.”

“Do you really think that way?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Elves cannot be negotiated with in the first place. You will only waste your time and efforts since it is the same as reaching for the stars. I think it

would be more constructive to focus on taking care of the refugees and looking for other solutions.”

It was the truth. For at least 500 years, not a single human engaged with the elves. It was a fact that was commonly believed throughout the Lorasian Continent.

“They are stubborn and refuse to engage with humans. There was only one place that said it was possible. Fairy tales. That is, children’s fairy tales.”

“...”

“In the case that someone believes its possibility, I would think that the man has a mental age of about six years old,” said Javier.

“Six-years-old? Where’s your proof?”

“Me. I believed that I could befriend an elf until I was six years old.”

“Hmm... So what you are doing is skillfully reaming me out for being immature?” asked Lloyd.

“No.”

“Then what?”

“I am not pulling back any punches.”

“Dang. You aren’t even trying to sugarcoat it.”

“Because it is the truth.”

“But look at you. And where did you learn that expression from just now?”

“You. Since you used it several times, I came to get a grasp of its meaning.”

“Tsk... But too bad though. It looks like you’ve got it wrong this time.”

“Wrong? What do you mean?”

“What do you mean, my ass. I’m saying there is a way to acquire Elensia sap from the woods of the elves.”

“...”

“What. What. What. Why are you narrowing your eyes and glaring at me like that?”

“It’s nothing. I was just thinking if I should pay a visit to the lord tomorrow morning,” Javier said sternly.

“Why not?”

“To discuss with him whether we should put you in therapy or send you to the capital for recuperation.”

“...”

Lloyd clicked his tongue because it seemed that Javier was hell-bent on distrusting him. But Lloyd knew why Javier was acting that way.

The comment about putting me in therapy was harsh, but that’s understandable.

It really was understandable because the elves in the Everglow Woods had zero contact or engagement with humans. So it went without saying that they never ever conversed with the latter. And if anybody dared to step foot in the woods, the intruder was instantly put to death. Therefore, the suggestion to strike a deal with the elves in Lorasia was as foolish as tap dancing naked in the middle of the savannah in Africa.

After all, no one succeeded in talking with the elves for the past hundreds of years. No mighty lord, king, emperor, or swordsman.

Everyone had failed. The power of the sword master was useless. Sword masters were slowly moving creatures in the face of the elves who seemed to be able to transport through the air.

But the first one to shatter that absolute notion was Javier.

The pioneer of the Everglow Woods. Javier Asrahan. Although he said that sitting at the negotiating table with the elves was reaching for the stars, in the novel, he later shared friendship with the elves in the Everglow Woods. After more adventures, he and one of the elves start to develop feelings for each other.

Thinking about that part is making me hate him.

The Knight of Blood and Iron. As Lloyd recalled the story of the book, he glanced daggers at Javier.

Come to think of it, that really is the case. The man in the novel had a fling in every place he went. Goodness, what is he? An actual heart-stopper?

But the really funny thing was that Javier always blocked the women coming on to him with a wall as high as Arctic sea ice. And when Lloyd thought that far, his hatred increased.

“That’s why you’re no good, man,” Lloyd said suddenly.

“I am no good...? What do you mean?”

“You’re an enemy to the army of single men... I mean, come on. Use your imagination.”

“My imagination?”

“Yeah,” answered Lloyd.

Lloyd pushed back his trivial thoughts and focused on the Everglow Woods, which was the main topic of the conversation.

“The elves in the woods are not a problem. The Elensia sap can be attained. I mean it.”

If things went according to his plan, and if he could really get his hands on the Elensia sap, the pipes could be perfectly insulated. Lloyd was confident about this because the Elensia Tree’s sap, according to the novel, boasted an incredible ability to store heat.

Of course. Javier made his armor and helmet using the sap. And he fought against the dragon in it.

Even though the fire dragon breathed hellish fire out of its mouth, it failed to melt the armor made out of the Elensia sap as 99% of the heat was blocked from entering his body.

Javier was hit with the dragon's breath three times in a row. But what he said to himself afterward really is comical. What did he say? Oh, how warm?

Javier even felt sleepy because the dragon breath reminded him of a warm blanket near the fire in winter. Just like that, Javier was completely safe from the fire dragon, and after three straight days of battle, he succeeded in slicing its horn. This story of a great expedition took a page in the novel.

"So we just have to go and get the tree sap from the woods. If we can get our hands on that and smear it around the insulation pipes, the heat can be transferred to every floor of the complex without losing any. I'm sure of it."

And the remaining tree sap can be stashed to be used for a greater profit later on. Lloyd stared at Javier confidently with that scheme in mind. The same gaze was returned from Javier toward Lloyd.

"..."

"..."

After a lengthy exchange of gazes, Javier spoke first.

"Are you serious about that?"

"Yeah," answered Lloyd.

"This isn't a childish antic, whatsoever?"

"Of course not," assured Lloyd.

“Okay. Then if we are really making for the Everglow Woods, how do you plan on persuading the elves and striking a deal with them to hand over the Elensia sap?” demanded Javier.

“I will talk if you promise me your cooperation.”

“Why do you need my promise for that?”

“Well, I have a secret I don’t want to share with anybody. So? Are you in or not?”

“...”

“Well, if you’re not up for it, then leave it. I’ll go there all by myself. But do know that acquiring the sap will be delayed just as much. People won’t be able to enter the apartment complex next year. Oh, how sad. If only cynical Sir Javier gave his helping hand. Then, the refugees’ lives would be much easier this coming year.”

“...”

“Once the apartment complex is finished, they will be able to cozily spend the first snow day of next year. Kids will be making snowmen and merrily have snow fights and ride sleighs. But that won’t be happening in real life. Just in their poor heads. Why? Because heartless Sir Asrahan is denying cooperation.”

“...”

“So one of the boys will take the full gust of biting wind and murmur to himself, ‘Oh, oh, Patrasche...’ and hang his head. Not just him. There will be a poor girl who begs the others to buy matches in tears until despair sweeps over her. She would close her eyes in the harsh winter with nothing but only a single ember of a match. What’s the reason for that tragedy? Simple. Because heartless Sir Asrahan is denying cooperation.”

“...”

“Oh, oh, but despite a host of tragedies, heartless and and cold-hearted Sir Asrahan is-”

“I’m going,” interrupted Javier. “I will go with you,” said Javier as he gritted his teeth.

To this, Lloyd’s eyes glimmered and grew alive.

“You will?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“With me?”

“Yes...”

“To the Evertglow Woods?”

“Haa. Yes, I will.”

Javier opened and closed his fist, thinking about punching him in the face. The corners of Lloyd’s lips pulled up in satisfaction.

“You should have said yes earlier,” said Lloyd.

“Then tell me.”

“What? How to extract sap from wood?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

Javier was curious. He wondered what breathtaking and innovative method Master Lloyd came up with that he would brim with so much confidence in getting the Elensia Tree sap from the insolent and stubborn elves. Javier waited in anticipation. At the same time, he resolved to himself that he would try his best for the struggling people like the kid and his blind mother he had seen a while ago. As long as it didn’t involve defiling his honor as a knight by stealing or anything similar, he was ready to listen. The moment Javier made his resolution, the corners of Lloyd’s lips curved strangely.

“Simple,” Lloyd said at last, recalling the story of the novel. “We’re going to steal it.”

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Chapter 128: The Negotiation Table Is Now Open (1)

The Everglow Woods. Everything there glowed and was preserved warmly. It was a mysterious wood where spring lasted all year long. But it hadn't always been special. Originally, the woods was like any other forest in the eastern range until elves settled there 300 years ago. They were the descendants of elves that once served dragons. They were sickened by the human world and decided to lay low, casting a special spell on the woods and creating a paradise of their own.

"And it's not cold throughout the entire year nor is there sweltering heat. It's a place where perfect spring exists forever."

Now, Lloyd and Javier were at the foot of the woods. A scoff escaped Lloyd as he gazed at the marvelous sight.

Wow. It's so real that I'm here.

The place was so vivid that it was poles apart from what was described in the novel. There was a vast difference between his imagination and the actual place.

It's not just any spring. It's the best kind of spring. The biting winter wind just outside this place is gone, and flowers I can't name blossom here and there. With the butterflies and bees, everything that's unique to spring is here-

"Ah-choo!"

Javier sneezed after inhaling pollen.

"Hey, shh," Lloyd whispered as he flinched.

"I am sorry. I, I..."

"Cover your nose and mouth at once."

Javier barely managed to cover his mouth and nose before another sneeze came out. Though it was muffled, it nonetheless invited a glare from Lloyd.

“You... You do know where we are right now, don’t you?”

“Yes, I do,” answered Javier sheepishly.

“Then, why are you sneezing so much? Do you want to see the female elves or something?”

“Um, I had no choice. It just came out all of a sudden.”

“Wait, you’re not allergic to pollen, are you?”

“Of course, no- Eh... Argh...”

“Eh?”

“Eh... Whew... I-I am fine.”

“...”

No, you don’t look fine…

“Like I would believe that,” Lloyd said as he grew doubtful. “You’re allergic to pollen. This is bad. Do you see this place? Pollen is flying around everywhere.”

The environment was that bad. This whole place was worse than the fine dust situation in South Korea. It was as though someone was slapping chalkboard erasers right in front of the two or the pollen was heavily snowing down from the sky. The thick pollen could be accredited to the perpetual state of spring here. And if Javier turned out to suffer from a pollen allergy, that changed things for the worse.

“But you are a sword master. Can’t you control the sneezing?” said Lloyd.

“I cannot.”

“Why not?”

“Because it’s a natural occurrence.”

“Hold on. Does that mean it’s impossible to infinitely hold your pee even if you are a sword master?”

“Yes,” said Javier”

“Hmm... Sword masters really aren’t that much, eh?”

“...”

“Anyway, this won’t do. Here. Cover yourself with this first,” suggested Lloyd.

“...”

Javier took the handkerchief Lloyd held out, and he wrapped it around his face to cover his nose and mouth. Breathing soon became easier.

“Follow me.”

Javier then moved into the outskirts of the woods with Lloyd, and the plan he had revealed eight days ago came to his mind.

We are going to steal it.

When Lloyd suggested stealing the Elensia sap and solving the insulation issue at hand, Javier flew into a rage, objecting that it was an outrageous idea. Stealing the Elensia Tree sap in the Everglow Woods while avoiding the elves? Javier considered that it was more realistic to train a chicken how to sword fight and hunt tigers.

That’s the case even if it’s me.

Of course, Javier was a sword master. But he wasn’t confident about dealing with the elves. Anywhere else, he would have fooled the elves. But he was in the Everglow Woods.

The elves are said to notice even a small change in the air of these woods. And yet, we are going to fool them? I'm afraid Master Lloyd is overestimating my powers.

Javier was worried, but the plan was pushed ahead nonetheless. The following day, Lloyd went to the baron and revealed his plans in detail, causing a bit of a scuffle between the baron and Lloyd. But the result was always the same. The baron gave up and said yes to Lloyd's never changing stubbornness and thorough plan.

And we departed right away.

The following morning, they left the barony, and they arrived here after a seven-day journey. The plan, which Javier could've never imagined, was revealed to him.

"Good. We can start from here," Lloyd said.

"Do you mean extracting the Elensia Tree sap?"

"Uh-huh."

Lloyd stopped moving.

"Then, what am I supposed to do?" asked Javier, certain that his young master must have devised a plan. He was certain that Lloyd did have a plan. After all, it was Master Lloyd.

These woods belong to the elves.

Javier could never let his guard down. It was the case even if he was a sword master. At least within the boundaries of these woods, the elves were as equally sensitive and perceptive as him.

And Master Lloyd wishes to fool these elves' senses and extract the sap? I wonder what he has up on his sleeves.

Javier waited for Lloyd's response, his face hardened. But when he heard Lloyd, it darkened all the more.

“Run.” Lloyd’s short answer was heard.

“Excuse me?”

“Run. Straight ahead.”

“I’m not sure what you mean.”

“Don’t you know how to run?” asked Lloyd again.

“Of course, I do.”

“That’s a relief,” said Lloyd.

“So what, you want me to run? Just run?”

“Yeah.”

Lloyd chuckled.

“As far as you can go from here. And as fast and noisily as you can. Into the woods. But make sure you don’t get lost.”

“You...” Javier paused and stared at Lloyd. “You want me to become a scapegoat.”

“Yeah.”

“Aren’t you worried that it might be dangerous for me?”

“No.”

“...”

“I’m more worried for myself,” objected Lloyd.

“What are you saying...”

“Think about it. You are a sword master.”

“I am.”

“And you got triple circles with you.”

“That’s right.”

“So no matter how much these elves in this Everglow Woods try to come at you, they won’t be much of a threat to you.”

“Are you sure about that?”

“Yeah, and I’m sure about one more thing. I am in more danger than you are.”

“You, Master Lloyd?” asked Javier.

“Yeah.”

This was something Lloyd was absolutely certain about.

“You,” Lloyd said as he glanced around, “have no problem protecting your body, but what do I have?”

“So, the plan is for me to create a ruckus and draw attention, and you are going to extract the Elensia Tree sap in the meantime?”

“Now, you’re talking.”

“But it’s going to be too dangerous,” warned Javier.

“It’s all right. I have a plan.”

“Can I trust you on that...?”

“Are you worried about me?”

“That can’t be,” said Javier.

“Then?”

“I am scared that I’ll get scolded by the lord for losing you.”

“Aha. So you are scared of losing your job in this day in age of economic instability, eh?” asked Lloyd.

“That is accurate.”

“My, my, you’re making me cry with your concern. I’ll make sure you won’t lose your job, so focus on taking care of yourself.”

“Understood... I will trust you then.”

“If you know, then scram. But make sure you meet me within 30 minutes.”

Javier gave a short bow. Even though the young master was throwing nasty comments at him, Javier knew very well that the one who was in greater danger tonight was Master Lloyd, not him.

I pray he will be safe.

Javier wondered if Lloyd could succeed in extracting the sap without getting caught. A part of him thought that it would be more reasonable to find another way than to venture into this risky plan. But he knew very well that it was too late to turn back.

And Master Lloyd is still confident about this whole plan.

By now, Javier knew that Lloyd had something up on his sleeve when he was this confident.

So I just have to trust and get on board with his plan.

Swish! Javier drew his sword and leaped high, like a predator letting out a ferocious roar. Then, he raised the sword toward the sky and collided with his mana circle.

Kaboom! The powerful mana blast jetted toward the sky.

I am right here! Come and catch me if you can!

Javier zoomed through the woods with more speed, aiming to stay as far from Lloyd as possible. Just then, dozens of light green shadows appeared and dashed through the trees, almost flying”

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Dang, they’re really fast.

Lloyd was hiding in a bush, quietly observing where Javier had gone to. Javier was already nowhere in sight. Instead, Lloyd saw the mana blast blasting through the sky from where Javier was headed, as well as the intermittent flashes of something light green.

It must be the elves. They’re already tailing Javier.

Lloyd was impressed by how perceptive these elves were. It appeared that it was almost impossible to fool these elves in the woods.

But that’s only when they’re on the ground.

After observing the surroundings some more, Lloyd rose up. A shovel was already in his hand.

When I’m underground, it’s a bit of a different story. Though I can’t fool them completely, I’ll be able to buy some time.

Rustle. Rustle. Lloyd carefully dug the ground, creating as little noise as possible. Thankfully, the earth was smooth and soft without many stones. So the digging turned out to be a cinch, and as he continued to dig, the hole became deeper. 15 feet. 30 feet. 60 feet... Eventually, Lloyd was able to completely hide himself in the small cave.

Okay, time for my first disguise.

He got out of the cave and covered the entrance with some leaves and twigs. It was disguised to look like an animal’s cave. Once it was done, he stepped out again.

Now, time for the real digging. Energizer.

Ding Dong.

[The skill option of the Asrahan Core Technique, Energizer, has been activated.]

[The triple circle's efficiency has been brought to the max.]

[You are guaranteed to not get tired for the next 20 minutes.]

Ziiing!

Woah, it's been a while since I felt this way!

Every fiber of his body was charged with strength. The three circles rotated at maximum speed, and an inexhaustible vigor, which was as energetic and charged as energy drink commercials, swelled over Lloyd.

Let's goooo!

Fwish! Fwish!

The noise was kept to a minimum this time as well. But the shoveling was not. It was ferocious and relentless. Lloyd dug the cave vertically, moving downward. 15 feet. 30 feet. 60 feet. But of course, Lloyd was never exhausted. Moreover, he already saw the path he had to go in advance.

The roots should appear anytime now.

This part of the land Lloyd started to dig was actually the area about 20 yards away from the Elensia Tree. But he couldn't thoughtlessly access the tree. If he reveals himself and tries to extract the tree sap and slice the trunk husk, what would happen?

I'd get beaten up.

Lloyd was certain about it because he had read it happen in the novel. Some of the explorers dared to extract the sap in such a manner, and they were captured by the elves. Lloyd shook his head as he recalled that part of the story.

Their attempt was off-base in two ways. First, they were exposing themselves on the ground. Second, this was the bigger reason. They only cut the husks, which only rendered a few drops a day.

In order to attain a large volume of sap, he needed to target the root, not the husk. That was the lesson Lloyd had learned from the failure of the explorers. It was so because the Elensia Tree stored the sap in its roots.

So, I simply need to cut a few thick roots to bring home and squeeze the sap out.

Inspecting the plan in his head once again, Lloyd accelerated his shoveling, and right before the Energizer ended, he discovered the root.

Okay. I see it.

Flash! Lloyd was actually activating another skill at the moment, and so the 16 feet space ahead of him was scanned in his eyes. Thanks to his skill, he was able to see it.

It's a root. I'm sure of it.

Lloyd tightened his grip, and at last, the shovel head reached the area near the root.

Thud!

A corner of Lloyd's lips curved upward.

Bingo. Found it.

From then on, Lloyd's shoveling became more detailed. As though he was spooning a pudding with a teaspoon or rifling through his ears for earwax, Lloyd scraped and removed the dirt off the tree root. Lloyd started to sweat very much. At last, the actual root of the Elensia Tree was seen in his naked eyes.

"Yikes."

This is massive.

Lloyd picked up the torch placed beside him in amazement. The Elensia Tree root was thick and transparent like glass. A milky liquid was filled in its smooth husk.

That's the sap.

Now that he checked, it was time to extract the root. Lloyd cut three strands of the root cleanly and wrapped them in oil paper in several layers before putting them in his bag. But he wasn't satisfied with it, and he made sure that he didn't climb out of the cave so fast. He instead held up the torch and brought it near the root. And in a soft and relaxed voice, he spoke.

"You sisters sneaking behind me. Stop right there. Take one more step, or aim your arrow at me, and I'll burn this tree to the ground"

Lloyd's thick voice rang aloud in the cave. The elf ladies, who were entering the cave, stopped.

"Are you... trying to take hostage of us when you're the one cornered in an impasse?"

Moira, who was aiming the bow behind Lloyd's back as she stood in the front, asked, her facial expression looking flustered. Lloyd smiled as though he had all the time in the world.

"Yes, I am."

They can't shoot me anyway, Lloyd thought to himself. So his plan would be a sure-fire success. Filled with conviction, Lloyd brought the torch near the end of the root.

"Or you can always shoot me if you want."

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Chapter 129: The Negotiation Table Is Now Open (2)

“Or you can always shoot me if you want.”

“…!”

Crackle! A spark of fire erupted from the end of the Elensia Tree root. Moira’s eyes widened in surprise while Lloyd curved the corners of his lips.

“How much should I burn? Do you prefer medium? Well-done?” growled Lloyd.

“S-stop...!” shouted Moira.

“First, I think you should put down that bow in your hands,” stated Lloyd.

“...”

Moira’s Adam’s apple bobbed. The tree couldn’t be harmed at all costs. She would rather burn herself instead. This was wrong. At last, she let go of the bowstring, and it hung down in her hand.

“Now, I did what you asked. Don’t hurt the tree,” said Moira.

“Of course.”

Lloyd pulled the torch slightly, and the end of the root stopped warping.

Okay, I succeeded in taking a hostage.

Lloyd looked around the narrow cave which he had just dug. It was so narrow that it would be hard for even one person to pass through. And Lloyd was trapped in such a cave with five elf ladies glaring at him at the entrance.

I’m helplessly trapped in here.

Lloyd smiled wryly at his predicament. But actually, he had expected this to happen early on, for there was no way he could hide from the acute senses of the elves in these woods.

That was why I created my plan with this situation in mind from the very beginning.

The Knight of Blood and Iron. Lloyd referred to the features of the elves from the novel. He studied and delved into the details, deliberating over several different solutions. The operation was finally established with several steps. First, use Javier as bait. Second, get to the root by digging a cave. Third, threaten the elves by taking hostage of the Elensia Tree and setting fire to its root.

And fourth, exchange hostages.

Lloyd moved one hand into his inner pocket and fished out something he took great care not to break. It was a wildflower he had picked before he started digging this cave.

"…!"

When he held up the flower, the faces of the elves trembled once again. Lloyd closely brought the torch to the flower.

"Everybody back off. Unless you wish to see this flower burn."

"H-how evil!"

"Come on now," growled Lloyd.

Their eyes shook like an earthquake. It was trembling so heavily that one would have wondered why they were acting that way. It was just a flower, nothing precious or extraordinary. It was just a common, nameless flower found in a field.

But the thing is, this kind of threat works on elves.

Corners of Lloyd’s lip rose. Yes. The Knight of Blood and Iron. The novel spoke of this secret characteristic of the elves. They were maniacal plant lovers.

Their love isn’t ordinary. It’s obsessive.

The elves held an extreme love for plants, and it was worse than the obsession some movie characters showed over certain objects or people. Even a simple act of stepping on an acorn by mistake caused them overwhelming sadness. They sobbed all day if they tore a leaf as they hopped over tree branches. And now, here was Lloyd, threatening to set a wildflower on fire. Their reaction was obvious.

“...”

They stepped back as they gritted their teeth. To this, Lloyd opened his eyes wider and said, “Farther. Keep going.”

“...”

The elves slowly stepped back, and Lloyd moved forward just as much. Moira looked daggers at Lloyd as she gritted her teeth.

“Your threat won’t be able to get you out of this forest,” she said, trying to knock some sense into this human.

“That’s not something for you to worry about,” huffed Lloyd.

“...”

“Keep moving back. Farther. Go on. Faster.”

“What if I say no...?” Moira asked.

“This flower burns.”

“But you will perish in our hands if the flower burns,” threatened Moira.

“Then,” Lloyd said,” today will be my last day.”

“...”

“Oh, well. That’s life.”

Lloyd stared straight into Moira’s eyes. He knew that in this kind of confrontation, the first to cower lost. He had to plant in their heads that there was nothing for him to lose. The psychological warfare must have worked, thankfully. For Moira bit her lips and took one more step back.

“Good choice.”

Lloyd realized that he had become the villain in this situation. While a sense of shame washed over him, the elf ladies moved to the far end of the cave. Lloyd motioned them with his chin and spoke.

“Go out. Outside.”

“...”

He drove the ladies out of the cave. But Lloyd remained inside.

Obviously. I don’t want my head to be pierced with an arrow.

The area outside the cave was an open space, so Lloyd could be sniped at from any direction. Knowing this very well, Lloyd persisted at the entrance of the cave and waited.

Javier should be here soon.

He had told Javier to return here within 30 minutes, no matter what. Once he got here, the ladies would fight back. And when chaos broke out, Lloyd would try to sneak out of the woods. Lloyd was confident that he would succeed.

My goal isn’t to fight the elves and take over this forest. The goal is just to run away. And since Javier is a sword master, I say it’s possible enough.

The nighttime getaway. This was the last stage of the operation he had devised for tonight.

Anyway, the elves were just as I expected.

As Lloyd waited for Javier, he never tore his gaze away from the elves. He was afraid that they would immediately shoot an arrow the moment they caught him lowering his guard. And so, he was able to observe even the smallest details of their appearance.

White complexion. Sharp ears. And these are all ladies who came to capture the intruder. It was true what had been written about them. Elf men do house chores while women shoot arrows.

The men were in charge of cleaning their houses. Women were in charge of inspecting the woods for any suspicious activities. This custom was mentioned in the novel. But there wasn't any particular or grand reason behind this.

Since men are larger and heavier than women, they're more harmful to the grass when they move around the forest.

And so, Lloyd read that the elf ladies learn a special step technique to protect the grass. Only when they perfect the technique can they be acknowledged as adults and go outside the village. This tradition was comical from a human perspective. But it was reasonable enough when you considered their obsessive love for plants.

But anyway, that's that. Why are they so gaunt?

The dragging engagement with the elves taught Lloyd one thing more about them. It was that they were seriously all skins and bones.

I'm not mistaken.

It was dark at night, and the only sources of light were the moonlight and flickering torch. And yet, they were still overwhelmingly visible.

They're not slim. They're gaunt.

Lloyd's gaze moved toward their faces. Every single one of them had protruding cheekbones. And their eyes were sunken and hollow. Not to

mention, their faces had an odd shade to them, and their grips that held the bows trembled faintly. It was weird.

Hold on. Something's off.

Lloyd's gut feeling tingled, and from then on, he avidly moved his gaze. He studied the full length of the elves and the woods around him. Things he had missed in his nervousness started to come into view.

These woods... I don't see any animals.

The forest. This was a forest that hadn't been touched by any humans, and it was spring all year long. Despite that, there were barely any animals. The squirrels that should be jumping from one branch to another were nowhere in sight, as well as the birds. There weren't any chirping noises that should have come naturally. In its stead, this forest was filled with dead silence.

How is this possible?

Lloyd was curious. He then gazed at the elf ladies once again. The plant-loving elves. Their emaciated faces from prolonged hunger. This forest is without any animals.

Wait a second. Is this...

He processed this in his head fast, making an intelligent guess based on the visible facts and speculations. The puzzle was pieced together, and a possibility popped into his head. Lloyd developed a theory at last, with which he came up with a new plan. And he uttered the plan out loud.

"Do you... by any chance like meat?" asked Lloyd.

"…!"

The elves' eyes trembled. Lloyd was right. A mischievous smile formed on his face.

I'm right. They are starved of meat.

These elves loved plants. They cherished and regarded them on an obsessive level. They never ever damaged any of them, and so, they never ate one. Not a single fruit, seed, leaf, stem, or root. Nothing.

They're meat lovers. Hardcover meat eaters.

Meat. Their diet consisted of nothing but meat, and nothing else. Their gaunt and frail appearance then suggested only one thing.

They haven't been able to eat meat for quite a long time.

Lloyd wondered why. The answer was found easily.

Monster domino. The phenomenon affected even this place.

The Everglow Woods sat in the eastern range, so it could not be completely free from the monster domino phenomenon. What was the result?

It's obvious. Some monsters would have caused a ruckus here, but of course, the elves would have repelled them. The problem would be what came next. The ecosystem would have been disrupted by the sudden appearance of the monsters.

Lloyd could instantly infer from the dead silence and absence of animals in this place. A large number of small animals have likely migrated out, and as a result, their predators left this place in search of another place to inhabit.

That's why the number of animals dropped. And from the elves' perspective, this means a drastic decrease in hunts.

Hunting would probably be unsatisfactory for a certain period of time now. Even though they sprinted around and shot arrows, they would have acquired only a small volume of meat. Lloyd's postulation was on point. In actuality, these elves were considerably starved, and they could not pinpoint the last date they hunted successfully and enjoyed a nice meat jerky. They couldn't even remember it well. They were hungry and weak.

But not just these ladies here. Everyone in the tribe was starved. All the men, women, and children. The situation was grave and desperate. But

there wasn’t any solution since the number of animals was reduced to a great level in these woods and the ones around it. Their hunts grew scarce. Of course, the situation would improve over the years, for nature didn’t like vacancies. In the far future, the animals that left this place would come back to restore the lost vivacity. But the elves didn’t know when that would happen and whether they could hold up starving until that happened.

The food shortage was already giving them a headache, and now, a human had dared to enter the woods! Moira thought to herself.

And this person ventured to damage the Elensia Tree root and threatened to burn a beautiful flower. The elves in the place felt their heads throb.

“You... What are you really up to?” blurted Moira. Her plan was to distract him until he let his guard down for a split second. She would use that moment to bore a hole in his head.

“Nothing,” said Lloyd, acting thick-skinned. “But...”

“But?”

“I want to negotiate.”

“Negotiate with us?”

“Yes,” said Lloyd.

“We don’t strike deals with humans. I am sure you know that very well,” said Moira.

“But you are doing so at this very moment.”

“...”

“And you even took heed of my threat. Isn’t a threat technically a form of negotiation,” said Lloyd.

“Don’t push your logic here. And I don’t intend to make a deal with you.”

“So what, you are going to kill me after the fire is out?”

“Are you afraid of dying?” Moira asked.

“Obviously.” Lloyd grinned at her before nonchalantly blurting out a suggestion too sweet to deny. “I can cook you some grilled pork, you know.”

“What...?”

“Sizzle. Sizzle. Oh, how tasty and savory grilled pork is. When it’s burned crisp, turn it the other way. And after it’s perfectly grilled, just cut it up with scissors. And dip it in some sauce... Whew!”

“...”

The eyes of the elf ladies grew slightly dazed. Lloyd continued to talk.

“Well, tell me if you prefer chicken to pork. Why? Chicken is just a way of life. Wash the chicken in water and spice it up with salt. Put it in milk for a day, and fry it for seven minutes in 330 in the fire. Then, three more minutes at 350. Just imagine. Imagine the juicy meat that would erupt in your mouth after you take a bite of the drumstick. Imagine the aroma that wafts out when you rip its juicy breast.”

“...”

“Oops,” continued Lloyd, “maybe your refined tongues prefer beef. Beef is best cooked as a steak. Remove the blood from the feather blade. And salt it up. Next? Simple. Throw the steak in a searingly hot pan. And turn it every minute. Oh, how the oil sizzles! Turn to medium heat, and grill it up to your preference. Woo, everyone would be drooling as they wait for it to rest!”

“...”

“Now, what do you say?” said Lloyd.

Gulp. Instead of giving an answer, the elves swallowed as their mouths salivated. The negotiation table, which Lloyd wanted, was now open.

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Chapter 130: The Negotiation Table Is Now Open (3)

Swooosh! Arrows flew, and the air particles split as they moved forward.

Crash! An arrow flew to pierce into a rock. Javier stepped on the arrow stuck onto it and leaped high.

Leap! He leaped like a bolt of lightning. But he didn't have any time to enjoy the flight as another shower of arrows came from behind to pierce the back of his head.

Thwackk! Crash!

Javier twisted his body midair in a hurry, and five arrows almost brushed his body. Three arrows hit the earth while two more arrows pierced into a rock. Just then, Javier realized two things: first, darkness didn't matter in the slightest to the elves. Second, they shot in a way so that the trees or patches of grass didn't get hurt.

This is outrageous.

This chase was happening breathtakingly fast. Javier was running through the dark and thick woods. And the arrows flew so accurately and fast that chills crept up behind his spine. What was more chilling was the fact that these arrows hit only the empty ground and rocks.

I'm moving at full speed, and yet, they can predict my movement with their senses. The angle and environment of the incoming arrows are all calculated in their heads. Each shot is the result of a meticulous calculation.

The more Javier thought about it, the more amazed he was. But it wasn't the time to marvel at their prowess.

Tap! Javier landed and jumped high again. He moved through the trees and bushes and zoomed forward. Chills ran down the back of his head and his

back. Dozens of arrows were flying at him, and the mere noise they created as they left the string stung his skin.

But I can't be caught so easily.

If he got caught, Master Lloyd would be in danger. So he could never let them catch him. He would do his best in his role tonight, which was letting the elves recklessly chase him. Thinking so, Javier sped up. But the elves started to corner him.

Swish! Fwish! The arrows that only flew from behind started to come from the side as well.

"...!"

Slash! Javier wielded his sword, slicing the two arrows with his sword blade. He bounced away the other one right so narrowly before it pierced his forehead.

"..."

Javier realized that he was being cornered. This was bad.

I was told to come back within 30 minutes.

There was something else he needed to do besides avoiding the clutches of the elves. It was to meet Lloyd after successfully distracting their attention away from his young master. The timing was wrong, and Lloyd could be put in danger. Javier wondered if he could make it within 30 minutes.

I might be a bit tight on time.

The elves were chasing him relentlessly, cornering him with every bone-chilling shot. But now, it seemed that he had to turn back and rush into the path where he came from. This only meant that he had to break through the siege head-on.

No time to waffle anymore. It'll be too late if I go any further.

Javier made a decision, which was to turn back at the creek ahead and jump into their siege. He would protect his body by wielding his sword that was charged with aura. If possible, he would threaten them with the mana blast to make sure they would retreat.

Perfect.

He finalized his plan in seconds. He jumped three steps forward, and four arrows were nailed to the ground as they swooshed in the air. Just then, Javier's eyes glinted.

Now!

Leap!

Javier instantly wheeled around and brought his sword to his chest. A brilliant ray of light, the aura, appeared.

Fwoosh!

The moment the aura appeared, Javier wielded his sword 57 times in accordance with the wind current and the way the pollen flew, creating a storm of aura.

Clang! Clang! Clang! Clank! Clank Slash!Fwoosh! Kaboom!

86 arrows flying at him were sliced in an instant, sending the arrowheads to the ground and the body back to the owners in the woods.

"...!"

The elf archers panicked in confusion as the shots they thought to be perfect were sliced by the aura and sent back to them again.

"Argh!"

"Ack!"

A handful of them, who failed to evade the counterattack, were struck. Some were hit in the shoulders. Some were hit in the shin. But no one was injured. It was comparable to a small sting or slap. But the elves didn’t have any time to focus on the burning pain.

That human is trying to break through us!

One elf hinted as she gazed at another. The rest of them picked up Javier’s intentions soon.

Thwack!

The silver-haired human in front of them charged forward, and this time, he was more forceful and relentless, unlike when he was trying to flee earlier. It was easy to see what he was doing. Breakthrough, not escape. Direct hurtling.

“...!”

Of course, the elves would never open the path for him so easily. Once the 86 elves realized what Javier was doing, they all pulled their bowstrings at the same time. Javier was about 50 yards away. Everyone’s eyes glimmered coldly. Javier’s speed. The direction and force of the wind. The humidity and density of pollen in the night sky. The elves instinctively calculated everything, and as they pulled their strings and aimed about 24 yards ahead, the arrowheads shone brightly. Deathly glare appeared in their eyes. 24 yards ahead of them was a tiny opening between the bushes, which was as small as the eye of a needle. There. That area will be the very venue where this silver-haired intruder would be pierced to death.

Stretch!

The veins on their arms popped out of their skins. The bows were pulled all the way to the back, and they bent to the point of breaking. They were about to let it go, but just then...

“...!”

There came a whistle. Soft but loud at the same time. It was only audible in the ears of the elves, and it was used to put a halt to the chase and chaos.

“...”

The archers looked at one another in confusion, but no one understood the sudden hearing of the whistle. Even still, they had to obey the signal as it was the way of life they had internalized over their years in the woods.

Rustle. The elves pulled away the bows and hid in the darkness. Some hid in the shadows cast under the beech tree. Some hid in between the vines, while some chose behind the rocks where the moonlight was unreachable. They left the scene so naturally, like sugar melting in the water. It was as if they were melted in the shadows. As such, Javier was confused.

Thump! Javier simply jumped and passed over the elves’ designated killing area, releasing energy from his sword to protect his whole body. However, it was strange.

What’s happening?

No one shot him. Not a single arrow flew in his direction. Something else was also gone.

The blood thirst that hung around the place was gone.

But Javier didn’t stop charging ahead as he knew that he could be easily taken down should he stop now. That could be something the elves were after, perhaps. So Javier kept sprinting while trying to make sense of the situation.

Something’s off. What is it?

Throughout his travels, Javier didn’t feel the presence of the elves that tried to take him down. It was as if the zealous chase that had taken place some minutes ago was all a lie or a dream.

How strange.

Javier wondered what in the devil these elves were up to. But instead of letting his guard down, he grew more alert and vigilant. At the same time, nervousness started to creep up on him.

Could it be that something happened to Master Lloyd?

Javier direly wished that wasn't the case. But he was nervous as the elves had suddenly halted their chase and decided to let him go as though nothing had ever happened. Javier's anxiety grew with every step he took. The silence around him made him more anxious.

I shouldn't have left him alone there.

Even though Javier became a scapegoat, Lloyd was already exposed to a considerable amount of danger. Javier knew that but foolishly trusted his young master's confidence too much. He had conveniently thought that Lloyd would have a plan in his head. He simply passed over the grave responsibility to Lloyd, which was making sure he stayed safe.

Please... Master Lloyd.

Please be safe and well, Javier thought to himself. He prayed that Master Lloyd would later welcome him in his usual nonchalant and brazen manner. Javier longed and longed for it as he rushed through the woods, growing hastier and speedier with every second. He jumped over rocks and thick trunks and slithered through the branches and twigs. The handkerchief that covered his nose and mouth was removed, and pollen started to assault his senses. But he didn't care. He simply barreled through the woods until he arrived at where he had started. The place where he had left Lloyd.

"Master Lloyd!" yelled Javier.

Slide! Screech!

Javier stopped dead in his tracks, sliding as he landed. He turned and glanced around to hurriedly search for Lloyd. The elves? Javier said to himself, resolving to respond the moment he spotted them. Even if it meant killing some of them and being chased for his life, he would rescue Lloyd

first. Javier gripped the sword with a deathly determination, but before he found them, he was discovered first.

“Hey. You’re here?”

Javier turned at lightning speed to the source of the welcoming voice and the smell of grilled meat. And there, he saw Master Lloyd with five elves, all seated around in a circle. They surrounded a grill with sizzling cuts of meat being cooked.

“What... are you doing right now?” asked Javier.

“Hm? We’re grilling some pork belly right now.”

“What about... them?” Javier said as he pointed at the awkwardly seated elves. His finger trembled.

“I’m eating with them,” Lloyd beamed as he answered.

“...”

“You’re right on time. Take your seat.”

Lloyd spoke as he tapped the empty seat beside him. Javier sat down on the rock as though he was entranced and naturally joined the elves as the meat sizzled on the pan.

“What is happening-”

“Introduce yourself to them,” said Lloyd. “These are the archer elves. In particular, she is Moira, the chief of the Myosotis tribe that settled here in the Everglow Woods.”

“...”

“See that?” went on Lloyd. “This guy is taciturn and not very social. He’s Javier Asrahan, my personal knight I told you about a while ago.”

“...”

Moira and the other elf archers greeted him awkwardly at Javier with their eyes. Blankly staring at them, Javier felt that these elves, too, were overwhelmed with embarrassment as they greeted him.

“So, tell me, what’s happening right now?” Javier groused after he managed to collect his thoughts. Javier felt cheated. He was sincerely concerned about his young master, so he rushed to get here. And yet, this was the situation they were in? What on earth happened between Master Lloyd and the elves while he was gone that they would be sitting around the fire grilling pork belly like some good friends? Javier thought to himself.

I can’t wrap my head around this at all.

Confusion rushed through him. But Lloyd was completely unaware of the latter’s feelings for he simply continued to grin at Javier.

“What do you think I’m doing? We’re in the middle of a negotiation,” said Lloyd.

“You’re negotiating?”

“I don’t have time to explain. Just sit and watch. Now, take the tong. Make sure you flip the meat before it burns.”

“...”

Javier took the tong in a daze, and he flipped the meat on the pan in his stupor. Meanwhile, Lloyd and chief Moira continued their discussion.

“Haha, how’s the meat?” asked Lloyd.

“It’s good...”

“Right? I heard that elves don’t use fire,” said Lloyd.

“For obvious reasons. Fire is created in the sacrifice of the plants.”

“Is that why you dry your game meat raw and process them into a jerky?” inquired Lloyd.

“It’s quite tasty, you know,” defended Moira.

“Tastier than this meat?”

“...”

“I knew it. Grilling pork belly like this is never the wrong thing to do. Tell me, are you bothered by the smell of coal in the meat?”

“Not at all.”

Moira shook her head shyly, and her eyes moved downward toward the fiery coals.

“It’s surprising. I didn’t know you can start a fire without sacrificing trees or depending on magic,” commented Moira.

Coal. Rock that started a fire. She was stupefied when she first laid her eyes on it. It was more than surprising, she felt emotional. She had never imagined that such a thing existed.

A rock that starts a fire? I never knew there was something like this.

Coal could be used to start a fire without throwing wood there. This meant that they could grill their game and cook them nicely. Moira’s eyes started to hold a glint of desire that was thick and deep as a cup of espresso. Lloyd was quick to catch the change of emotion right away.

Well, well, I expected it but never really thought the elves would be drawn to coal.

Lloyd had packed some coal to help start a fire. And the meat and pan were meant to encourage him on the cold journey. So he never imagined that these items would work so wonderfully to facilitate a deal with the elves. Seriously, even Lloyd, who liked to draw out large plans, considered himself lucky.

“Well, anyway, to continue the negotiation... give us what I ask, and I shall supply you with a generous amount of meat and coal every month.”

“Coal? Do you mean this burning coal?” Moira asked.

“Yes.”

Technically speaking, the coal wasn’t a rock. It was a tree that died and was buried trillions of years ago. But Lloyd decided that it was superfluous to tell her that.

“What I demand is simple,” Lloyd said as he brushed away the thought of what coals actually were. “The right to extract the sap of the Elensia Tree roots. Of course, I won’t recklessly go about extraction. I will take the exact amount approved by your tribe under your supervision. And...”

“And?”

“Send us 100 elves who can jump from great heights without fear. They will be working as metal workers in my fiefdom. It will be a sort of outsourcing,” Lloyd said.

Juicy meat. Marvelous coals. Lloyd dropped his demands on the negotiating grilling pan as he revealed the two cards he held in his hands.

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Chapter 131: Dancing on the Rebars (1)

“Welcome. I hope the journey was kind to you. You are now in the Frontera barony.”

“...”

Lloyd Frontera’s voice rang aloud in her ears. The chief of the Myosotis tribe, Moira, lifted her head, and a vast and familiar scenery appeared in front of her.

So, that must be the land of humans.

She surveyed the Frontera barony at great length. The first thing she noticed was the Prona River, whose waters flowed from the south and largely turned clockwise in a semicircle. It then rounded west to flow out north. The Frontera barony sat within the semicircle.

The east touches the foot of the mountain range, and the other sides are surrounded by the river.

It was a beautiful sight to behold. But she realized one uncomfortable truth.

Too many plants are sacrificed amid the beautiful scenery.

Small villages sat here and there throughout the fiefdom, and the paddies and fields stood among them. The reclaimed land stretched vastly in the north. Those areas were designed and used to harvest plants and vegetation by mass, all at the necessity of humans. The same went for several houses and buildings.

All the structures use wood.

The log houses, stables, and storehouses all were built using wood as the main material. This uncomfortable truth made Moira’s heart throb in pain.

I bet these poor trees never received a proper funeral.

Humans didn’t consider plants valuable enough to go to such lengths for them. As such, they never paid their respects to dead trees. This sight naturally brought...

“Are you uncomfortable?”

“...”

Lloyd, who must have understood Moira’s feelings, asked as he stood right beside Moira. She nodded softly at his question. The corners of his lips rose.

“We don’t have a choice. For everyone has a different way of life.”

“Different way of life?” asked Moira.

“For instance, the monks.”

Monks?

Moira had never heard of such a word before. The smile on Lloyd’s face deepened slightly.

“They are a sort of priest in a faraway region,” explained Lloyd.

“A priest? Why are you bringing it up now?”

“They keep a diet that is poles apart from yours. They only eat plants.”

“What in the world...”

Moira was terrified. Eats only plants? That was just awful. But when Lloyd explained further, she was prompted to rethink her stance.

“To keep the rule that forbids killing. They only eat plants out of respect for living beings. Sure, there are some who do not abide by the principle. But most of them strive to keep it, according to what I have heard. It is the same with you, who cherish and value plants.”

“...”

“I am saying this to ask for your understanding as we all have different ways of life,” said Lloyd.

“Understanding? Just like the negotiation you had offered a few days ago?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd gently nodded, and his response made Moira take a trip down memory lane. A few days ago, this intruder had entered their forest and dared to take the sap of the Elensia Tree. When he was cornered, he took the sap hostage and had the audacity to grill meat in front of them. Not enough with that, he tried to strike a deal by promising to provide them with meat and coal. Even right now, Moira could not forget the words spoken through this man’s mouth.

***

“Negotiation is all about narrowing the distance between the interests of two sides,” Lloyd said.

Moira felt odd, and she wondered what he was talking about. Lloyd continued to speak.

“Well, we don’t have to narrow it by force. After all, some negotiations do break down. However, the mere attempt to close the distance between the two sides is a good start. Just like how we are sitting across from each other when everybody has said that the two races can never come to an agreement.”

Lloyd chuckled.

“Anyway,” he went on, “let us summarize what I had offered once again. I promise monthly provision of meat as your tribe needs it. Along with coal, the rocks that sustain a fire, which you can use to grill the meat.”

“In return,” Moira said, “you want us to grant you the right to extract Elensia Tree sap and 100 workers?”

“That is exactly right,” affirmed Lloyd.

“...”

“You can reject my offer if you don’t like it. Or if you want to receive something more, please do tell us now.”

“Are you going to grant it if you hear me out?” asked Moira.

“That depends. Let’s hear it first.”

“...”

Moira wondered if this was what a negotiation, which the human was calling it, was all about. One side makes an offer and the other side counteroffers. And they weigh the benefits. Moira had never ever experienced this before. She has led a peaceful life as she spent all her days hunting in the vast woods. A sense of hesitation rushed through her at the face of the negotiation. And she fell deep in thought.

What would my mother have done if she were alive?

Her mother’s name was Roscia, and she used to engage with humans in the fiefdom called “Gapelle.” Though she couldn’t remember exactly, Moira remembered hearing from her mother that she had come back to the woods and had Moira after her human friends passed away one by one. Just then, her mother’s will that was left before she went back to the spirit of the plants called to Moira’s mind.

She said that human friendships are transient. That they die too early and meaninglessly, unlike us. So, she told me to trust only human friends. Trusting the entire race was only going to put me in trouble.

And now, this human named Lloyd was...

Not a friend. But…

He didn’t look like an enemy either. The so-called negotiation was proof of it. Plus...

“Why are you taking off your armor?” asked Moira.

“Oh, to make a contract.”

“What do you mean by a contract?”

“It’s a preservation of the terms of an agreement. It’s an important document that leaves physical evidence of the results of a negotiation. As a result, it prevents and reduces any misunderstandings and conflicts that may arise in the future,” explained Lloyd.

“So leaving this so-called contract erases the reason for a dispute?” asked Moira.

“Yes, most of them.”

“Most of them...? Why not entirely?”

“Because nothing is perfect in this world. Anyway, okay. Here we go. Turn it this way, and slice it up...”

Stab!

Lloyd took off his leather armor and removed a shoulder protector. After turning it upside down, he stabbed and sliced it with a dagger. Once he cut out a square, he looked at Moira and grinned.

“I’m going to use this as a contract. Normally, we write it on a piece of paper. But I didn’t think you’d like that very much as that’s another form of plant harassment from your standpoint. Right?” asked Lloyd.

“...”

“So, did you have enough time to think about it?” asked Lloyd once again.

“Yes, I did.”

Burning rocks and meat. These deals were good enough, especially for their tribe, as they were suffering from a food shortage. This deal was a sweet

rain in a drought. Moreover, she liked Lloyd's attitude of creating a contract on a level playing field. He didn't give any empty words of bravado. And the sight of him cutting out the leather armor for her impressed Moira.

"Okay," said Moira as she nodded. "I will take up your suggestion."

"And in return, the Elensia Tree sap and the workers?"

"Of course."

Just like that, she took the offer. Afterward, they wrote two copies of the contract and took one each. On top of that, they wrote an outsourcing contract for dispatching elf workers. This deal, however, invited harsh criticism from the tribal elders. They reamed her out for thoughtlessly handing over the root of the precious tree and for opening the woods to humans.

This is better than starving the children in our tribe.

This was her realistic concession and decision as a tribal chief. She would fully take the brunt of all the criticisms thrown at her. But she would make sure that her tribe would reap the benefits of the negotiation. Resolving as such, she jostled herself out of her trance. Her gaze traveled to the Frontera barony before it moved to Lloyd at her side.

"It is just as you said it," Moira said.

"Excuse me?"

Lloyd gazed at her in confusion. Moira faintly smiled at him.

"Well, it's all a matter of perspective. I now see it. The stance of humans, and their different lifestyles. So, where will we be working from now on?"

"Oh, do you plan on working right away?" asked Lloyd.

"Yes. That was a term in the negotiation."

Coal and meat. She would give as much as she received. Lloyd smiled in satisfaction after hearing her.

“Allow me to teach you how to work first. Okay, this way, please.”

Lloyd led Moira and 100 elves to the fiefdom. He first introduced them to the baron and the baroness. The people in the barony manor and fiefdom were flustered and amazed by the elves. Some of the young men fell in love at first sight, while a handful of girls sent gazes of adoration at them. And when Lloyd revealed what the elves would be doing from now on, the baron was caught by surprise.

“What? They would be put to work with the rebars?” asked the baron in disbelief.

“Yes.”

“D-do you really think that would be possible?”

“Yes, of course.”

“...”

Lloyd nodded his head, brimming with confidence. The baron was flustered.

“Um, but I... fear that it might be slightly difficult,” confessed the baron.

“Is it because of their fragile appearances?”

“Yes, although it is a bit wrong to judge them based on their appearance... Um, I cannot help but feel that way,” the baron said with hesitation in his voice.

It was true. These elves reminded the baron of mysterious and slender does. They looked like fairies who had never worked hard a day in their lives. But here was Lloyd, announcing that they would be thrown into construction sites and given the job of working on the rebars, which was extremely laborious and hectic.

“I am sure of you now,” said the baron. “Even the fearsome and rough orc warriors clamor in fear all day as they work on the rebars. They cry out loud that the building is too tall. Their cries have worsened in the few days you weren’t here.”

“Yes, I am aware of it. That is why I brought them here,” Lloyd said.

“Really?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd grinned.

“They are not afraid of heights. Plus, they are much stronger than you’d think.”

“What do you mean? They’re strong?” asked the baron, incredulous.

“Yes. They live ten times longer than us, and they dart around the woods and shoot arrows throughout their long lives.”

Archery. Most RPG games included this agile skill. But in real life, it was different. Very different. Anybody who had experience using a bow and arrow would know it very well. Archery required muscle, not agility.

“And they remain young for much longer than us. Their muscles grow during the entirety of those long years. Moreover, they practice archery every day, so you don’t have to question their strength,” said Lloyd.

Their youth was far longer than humans. And in the span of those years, the hormones that foster muscular growth were secreted the entire time. On top of that, they were carnivores who only ate protein-filled meat as they went around shooting arrows. So technically speaking, even the special force units would be cute children in comparison to these elves. The baron may have dismissed them as weak, but the truth was that they were far from it.

“So do not worry about it. And you can leave it to me to take care of them,” assured Lloyd.

“Hmm,” said the baron, “you have a point there.”

The baron was convinced. And the following day, Lloyd taught the elves the work process. Since they had no knowledge of construction work, they were educated on different concepts and precautions. In particular, Lloyd paid special attention to safety.

It’s nice that they’re careful by nature.

The elves were discreet creatures. They were slow to learn, but they made sure they internalized the lessons. The safety aspect of the construction was particularly the case. Once they finished their basic education, it was time to learn the rebars, which was their main task.

“So, laying the rebars is called rebar placement. Just like here, you do this and this. The important thing is to exactly lay the rebars according to the design. And when you tie the intersected rebars, you use this tool called a hooker.”

Lloyd taught them several ways to tie the rebars. Besides that, other techniques were shared with them as well. For instance, the way to unite the cement formwork, how to construct structural support to prevent any bending or tilting from pressure, and the procedure and safety guidelines for dismantling the formwork after the cement was dried. Lloyd put the elves through the wringer during this training period, showing no mercy.

“Over there, tie the rebars like that, and it’s going to bust. Wait, are you doing this because you don’t want to eat meat?”

“Excuse me? You should be laying them following the ink on the ground. Otherwise, I might not be able to give any meat today.”

“Hey. Erect the support like that, and it’s going to collapse. An accident will happen. And you know what happens if an accident occurs? I’m going to wrap the pork belly with vegetables!”

Lloyd’s most effective threat was to make a wrap out of lettuce, sesame leaves, and cabbage. During snack time, he would wrap their favorite meats

in vegetables along with some sliced peppers and garlic and show them to them. But he didn’t make them eat it. For showing it was enough. Almost all elves at the site were rooted to the spot. Some of the soft-hearted ones even broke into sobs, repenting for their mistakes. And as these hectic training sessions lasted several days, the elves grew up to become solid, trustworthy rebar workers and were dispatched to the construction site. Of course, Lloyd was with them.

“I will be personally supervising and overseeing your work here for the time being. How long? Until you get used to the job. So if you want to stop hearing my nagging, you can just quickly adjust to the field,” voiced Lloyd.

The elves flinched when they heard Lloyd. Were they still under his supervision even when he was at the site? A sense of awfulness swept over them. Lloyd was stringent when it came to nagging. And the experience of looking at lettuce-wrapped meat was just...

No. Just no. I don’t want to experience that ever again!

The elves resolved to themselves that they would exert the best concentration skill and be acknowledged by Lloyd. So that they would be saved from the terror of witnessing another lettuce wrap. Their determination and focus compounded to derive 200% of their athletic jumping ability unique to elves.

Jump! Swoosh! Creak! Clank! Tap!

The construction of Building 102 had been on a temporary halt because of the orc warriors and their fear of heights. But now, the site was filled with the elves who had begun to fly at the top.

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Chapter 132: Dancing on the Rebars (2)

Jump!

Moira stepped on the rebar and jumped high in the air. A thought crossed her mind. I'm free. How familiar. This feeling of being hundreds of feet off the ground. As she jumped high from the roof of the building made of rebars and cement, she surprisingly felt familiar akin to leaping on birch trees.

It feels like I'm back in the woods again.

Since she had spent her whole life in the Everglow Woods, she started to miss it even though it hadn't been a month since she left. The landscape, air, and smell. Every moment in this fiefdom was another moment of nostalgia for her home. But right now, as she flung herself in the air from the peak of the construction site, she was shocked to learn that she didn't miss the woods at all. It was all due to the surprisingly familiar feeling that washed over her.

It's similar to the woods. The height. The space, too.

The high-rise building and the pillars felt like tree trunks. And the tied-up rebars that protruded from the building reminded Moira of tree branches.

Jumping in between them feels similar.

Tap! Fwoosh! She jumped to the top of the rebar and surveyed the construction site as though she was hanging from a tree branch. She wondered if the other elves were feeling similar. They, too, had a glimmer in their eyes, which was different when they were on the ground. Everyone hopped and moved around the site as if they were riding the wind. To the others, they looked like they were flying.

Creak. Clank! The elf workers moved and tied the metals in a flash, riding the wind and dancing and sliding. And when they had to move from one floor to another, they did acrobatics.

Fwoosh! Moira threw herself out of the building, the ground just dozens of feet below. But she didn't plummet to the ground. She had already decided before the leap where she would land. The fall safety net.

Tap! Her feet touched the edge of the net, and she was sent high in the air again. The momentum sent her to the lower floor in no time, and she picked up the tool she had forgotten there. The process was the same when she went back up.

Tap! She kicked the safety net and stepped on the wall, the sheer speed letting her defy gravity and run up the building. Stretching her arm, she grabbed the window sill and entered the building through it. It took her only about two seconds to climb this high without taking the stairs. However, even though Moira just showed an exploit that no ordinary humans could ever perform so easily, the other elves were nonchalant about it. After all, what she did looked as natural as walking to them. What was more, the elves perfectly showcased what they had learned from Lloyd despite their intense movements.

My goodness. They're better than I expected them to be.

Lloyd's jaw dropped as he supervised the construction site. He wondered if those elves were born to be rebar workers. They were that wonderful.

I did a great job by bringing them here. With their current competence, Lloyd could assuredly leave the site to them. There was no more need for supervision. *But since mistakes are unavoidable even for the best masters, I better take precautions and lay a thick pad of hay on the ground just in case.*

The elves could fall under the safety net by mistake. And so, Lloyd thought to himself that he should take another preventive measure. But when he went down, he found the orc warriors cheering in the courtyard as they stared at the ongoing construction.

"Awesome! Oink!"

"Elves are the best, oink!"

“I was so scared to go up there, oink!”

“My girlfriend scolded me every night, oink!”

“My wife scolded me, oink!”

“My son scolded me, oink!”

“Liars! These guys are all single! oink!”

Thanks to the great work of the elves, the orcs were liberated from the rebar work and their fear of heights.

They are unimaginably fast as well. At this speed, we might be able to put up eight stories of Building 102 before it gets colder.

The winter was coming near, and Lloyd was secretly worried about it. Once the freezing winter began, the cement could no longer be deposited after the temperature dropped below 32 degrees.

It will freeze and thaw.

This was a phenomenon that had to be watched out for at any construction site.

Since water is used to make concrete, it will solidify into ice once the temperature goes below freezing. So, even before the concrete itself can dry up, the moisture inside it will condense and become ice.

If the concrete dried in that state, it would create ice particles and molecules from the water. That was fine in the winter since it remained frozen. But once the winter passed and the climate got hotter, the particles would melt, and the finished concrete would be left wet from the defrosted water molecules.

If that happens, the construction will be a failure. The concrete structure will dip below the designed strength. As a result, the concrete can crack, crumble and collapse, erode the rebars, or worse, bring about the pop-out phenomenon, where concrete blocks as big as fists tear out. In other words,

a disaster will unfold. The building will be useless. And if it's an apartment complex with about 1,000 residents in it... Ugh, the mere thought of it is just horrible.

Lloyd shuddered at the thought, his shoulders trembling. But now that he saw the speed at which the elves worked, he knew that he was free from such concerns.

The weather has been fine until now. So, we must finish the eighth floor in the next few days before it gets colder.

Lloyd encouraged the workers on the construction site with such determination. He sometimes coaxed and pushed the elf workers. Thanks to their hard work, the eighth floor, which had been slow in progress, was finished in no time, and the concrete was deposited there just within eight days.

Great. I love it.

Lloyd was greatly satisfied. Building 102 was erected on the top floor before the freezing winter came, so Lloyd was able to finish the insulation and heating of Building 101 and 102 during winter.

Building 101 and 102 will become a prototype. And based on their age and experience, I'm going to construct Building 103 to make sure I have another source of cash.

Lloyd pushed ahead to the next part of the process. It was the heating project of Building 101, which he had postponed for a while.

"So mix the bean oil with this precious sap?"

"Yeah."

The key to upgrading the insulation in the heating pipes was the Elensia Tree sap, and Lloyd poured some drops of it into the bean oil. This invited Javier's strange glances as though he was asking what on earth he was doing.

“Do we have a lot of Elensia sap? No, not at all. It’s a waste to use it as it is. And besides, there’s no need to do that,” said Lloyd.

“Is that why you’re diluting it with water?” asked Javier.

“Yeah.”

“But why bean oil out of all the other ingredients?”

“Since it’s cheap and easy to acquire, and it’s waterproof.”

What’s more, was the smell. It was nutty. And so, Lloyd mixed the sap and bean oil. But the ratio was a pickle. 1:1? Of course not. Then, conservatively, 1:10? That wasn’t it either.

“Master Lloyd... You’re not going to say that you ‘mixed’ the liquid when you just put a drop of the sap, are you?” Javier, who was struck dumb as he watched Lloyd, asked.

His response was understandable. Right now, Lloyd was mixing the two at a ratio of 1:99! But Lloyd was nonchalant as he spoke to respond.

“Hey, this is just the way of the world. Go try to buy a drink, and you’ll know it right away. You’ll be thankful if it contains at least one percent of the advertised ingredient.”

Truly, it was the way of the world. Go to any supermarket. Pick up any fruit-flavored drinks or jellies. The wrapper could advertise orange, strawberry, or another fruit in big letters. But if you checked the ingredients, it was common to find the product contained less than one percent of the fruit. Lloyd had been hurt by this realization during his tender youth. The unforgettable lesson of capitalism that hurt him still lived with him to this day. That day, he learned the magic of being a cheapskate.

“So, this is enough. We already tested the performance too,” said Lloyd.

“Is that so?” asked Javier.

“Of course. Take this jar. And the brush.”

“...”

“What are you doing? Come here quickly.”

Lloyd led Javier to the heating room of Building 101, and he pointed at the pipes that extended to the apartment complex.

“Do you see the pipes? Go apply the Elensia insulation cream on these pipes. Now.” ordered Lloyd.

“Technically speaking, they’re bean oil-based cream, aren’t they?” pointed Javier.

“Shush. The one percent is what matters.”

“...”

Lloyd and Javier started to apply the cream on the pipes, fanning them to make sure that they were properly dried. Next, the two wrapped them with a thick blanket of hay and fastened them with a straw rope. And when Lloyd and Javier tested out, the result was extremely satisfactory.

“How is it?” asked Lloyd.

“It’s very warm.”

“Right?”

“Yes.”

Prior to this job, the pipes on the eighth floor were cold. But after it was insulated with the Elensia insulation cream, they were warm as though the heating room was right beside them.

This will do. I’m perfectly fine with how it turned out.

The previous insulation was only mixed with wheat straw, chaff, and lime. But now, it was topped with Elensia Tree cream and hay. Lloyd felt the

worth of taking special care to wrap the pipes with several different layers. Just then...

“Excuse me, Master Lloyd?” called Javier.

“Hmm?”

Lloyd noticed that the way Javier called him was slightly different.

“You have a favor to ask me, don’t you?”

“...”

“I’m right. I’m completely right,” said Lloyd.

“How did you know?”

“You said ‘Excuse me’ before calling me,” said Lloyd as though it was so obvious.

“...”

“You know, you don’t usually call me like that unless you want something from me.”

Javier didn’t say anything. He simply stared at Lloyd.

“So?” Lloyd asked. “What is this favor of yours?”

“It’s about the refugees.”

“What about them?”

“How about letting those who are disabled or sick move in here first?”

Javier spoke frankly, but there wasn’t any particular reason for doing so. It was just that he remembered the event that happened a few days ago as he touched the warm pipes.

I wonder how that boy taking care of his blind mother is doing right now.

Javier's thoughts flew back to the event, and he recalled the environment the boy and his mother were in. It was lacking. Even though the refugee tents were built with care, they were nonetheless tents. They were uncomfortable even for healthy people. So, it went without saying how much worse it would be for the sick and disabled.

"Since refugees have to live a communal life where everything is exposed... It is my opinion that those who are sick will get better faster when they can peacefully reside in this building," explained Javier.

"Hmm."

Lloyd chewed over Javier's words, and he thought his points were quite reasonable.

"You're right," Lloyd agreed, "it's not helpful to put sick people in a cramped tent."

"Yes, I believe so."

"Then, should we let them move in first to take the bottom three floors? That way it will be easier for them to move up and down," suggested Lloyd.

"I like your idea."

The basic facility for Building 101 was all there. The heating was almost done, and so was the inside of each unit. The communal dining area and bathrooms only required a few more touches, which could be done even while people lived in the building.

Plus, it's going to help to see the residents actually living here.

There could be a discrepancy between reality and the design. Houses were always like that. The noise between units, dew condensation, draught, light, ventilation, etc... The design could miss out on certain elements that make it uncomfortable for the people who live there. As such, these patients can be made to live in the winter first, and Lloyd would observe them. They would

be the beta testers for Building 103, whose construction was to begin next spring. Its design could reflect the points of improvement found in Building 101 and would be upgraded to promise greater convenience for residents.

“We should then sort the patients, and those who are sicker will take the first floor,” concluded Lloyd.

The first group of people moved into the building. The patients in the refugee camps were transferred to Building 101, and everyone was touched to be there. Their response was nothing surprising as the monster domino had devastated their houses. They dragged their injured bodies to this fiefdom to live in a refugee tent for several months until a proper home was ready for them. So, it would be strange for them to not break into sobs.

“How grateful I am... I don’t know how to repay this debt...”

The first batch included the kid and his blind mother. She broke into tears as she touched the small unit given to live with her son. Just then...

Ding Dong.

A new message popped in front of Lloyd.

[Monumental construction achievement!]

[You have commanded the construction of the first apartment complex and occupation efforts in the Lorasia Continent.]

[The first batch of residents who moved into the building will be grateful to you for their entire lives, becoming the most faithful residents of this fiefdom.]

[You have left an indelible mark in the history of civil engineering on the Lorasia Continent.]

[You shall be remembered as the pioneer of the apartment complex in history.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 700 RP.]

[Current RP: 4,783]

It had been quite a while since he acquired RP. Lloyd forcibly pushed away this warm feeling in his heart as he responded cynically to the boy's mother.

"Ha, forget any debt. Raise your son well, and that will be all," said Lloyd.

And this boy would grow up to work for the fiefdom, and Lloyd would use the boy to his benefit. Repeat this process, and it would gradually fatten up Lloyd's cash cows.

Heh. You think I'm building this apartment for free?

Of course not. There was no such thing as a free lunch for Lloyd. There may be so for him. But it was never to be so for others, including these refugees.

But right now, the time isn't ripe yet. Just a little more. Once they settle in my fiefdom and get better, I'm going to put them to work.

They would be made to pay for everything they received from him. Lloyd was envisioning a sweet future in his head when someone panted and rushed to him.

"M-master Lloyd!"

Lloyd turned to find who it was, and it was a servant in the manor.

"Just...! Now!" panted the servant.

"Just what? What's going on? Come breathe now. Speak slowly," urged Lloyd.

"A r-royal messenger is here."

“What? A royal messenger? From the queen?” asked Lloyd.

The servant nodded.

“Yes, and he’s waiting for you, at the manor.”

“...”

When Lloyd heard the arrival of the royal messenger, something tingled inside him. He suddenly had a gut feeling.

Wait a second. Is this...

Lloyd made for the manor with the servant, and when he got there, he spotted the royal messenger chatting with the baron and the baroness. It was the same one that had come here to announce the queen’s order after Lloyd’s accomplishment in Cremo. Although it was the same person, his attitude was different from then.

“It has been a long time.”

The royal messenger was courteous and well-mannered, which was hardly the case back then. He had treated Lloyd with disdain.

“...”

The hunch in Lloyd grew stronger. Feeling the hunch grow into a conviction, Lloyd spoke.

“Please, let us do the procedure first.”

“Yes, let us,” replied the messenger, and he cleared his throat.

He looked around, and one of his men brought a scroll to him. The order of the queen. Lloyd got on one knee and waited for it to be read aloud. And Lloyd predicted that his hunch would be right and that the scroll would contain the very message he expected. At last, the messenger started to read.

“Since time immemorial, I, along with the great sovereigns that came before me, have worked hard to achieve peace and comfort for the nobles and citizens.”

What followed after was the usual stuff. The queen felt the burden of responsibility and that she was working hard day and night. Wretched by the recent disaster, she commended the Frontera barony for its achievements... Yada yada...

The messenger continued to read, complimenting and praising Lloyd with plenty of flowery words. As Lloyd listened to the messenger, his lips moved softly. Soon, his hunch finally developed into conviction. Lloyd continued to murmur softly as the messenger spoke aloud until his words matched the latter.

“Here ye! For the abovementioned achievements, I hereby grant the Frontera barony the status of a county.”

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Chapter 133: No Free Lunches (1)

“Here ye! For the abovementioned achievements, I hereby grant the Frontera barony the status of a county.”

Silence ensued right after the messenger ordered forth. No one dared open their mouths. The messenger, his delegation, and Javier... Everyone was silent until a little later when Baron Frontera, who now rose as Count Frontera, started to sob.

The baron immediately covered his mouth in an attempt to smother the choking sound. But it was no use. His wailing couldn’t be contained, and it kept spilling from his muffled lips. As tumultuous emotions rushed through him, his shoulders shivered terribly as a blanket hung outside during a storm.

Goodness... Goodness gracious. How do I make sense of this?!

The count couldn’t believe what he was hearing. But it had to be true. The messenger was standing right in front of him, holding a royal scroll. And the voice reading the order aloud was grave and serious. Everything was actually real and true.

What a blessing to my family...

Count Frontera hung his head lower as he muffled his sobbing. Meanwhile, the messenger continued to declare the order.

“Here ye once more! In accordance with the elevation of status, Frontera county may experience a hierarchic conflict with County Cremo, for it is the central fiefdom in the Cremona region. Therefore, the Frontera county shall be thenceforth directly under the control of the royal palace, separating from the administrative jurisdiction of the Cremona region.”

Oh, this is good.

The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose up as he heard the announcement.

A direct-controlled city, eh? It's a measure to prevent the hierarchy between the nobles from getting all twisted.

Come to think of it, this measure was an obvious one. The Frontera barony originally fell under the administrative order of Cremona county. But now that the baron had risen to become a count, he now enjoyed the same status as Count Cremo. One region with two count families would only breed conflict as the hierarchy jumbled between Count Cremo and Count Frontera.

So it's better to divide the administrative districts as independent entities. I knew my queen was a genius.

She was not only skilled in sword fighting. Her skill in politics was at another level. And next, the messenger proceeded to enumerate the various benefits that follow the escalation of status.

"Here ye once more! Therefore, the Frontera barony is hereby exempted from taxes to the royal palace for the next 20 years as it has been designated as the hub of reconstructing the eastern region."

Woah!

Lloyd's eyes widened in surprise. There were even more benefits that followed.

"Here ye once more! The royal palace shall assist the Frontera county for the next ten years by allotting supplies and a special budget for it."

Well, well, well!

By now, Lloyd was smiling ear-to-ear. The sweet benefits didn't end with that.

"Here ye once more! The Lacona viscounty, which sits near the Frontera county, shall be designated to fall under the direct control of the new county."

Viscount Lacona... Hahahahaha!!

Lloyd was so overjoyed that his shoulders started to tremble. He almost broke into wild laughter. More benefits followed after that. These included the right to receive investment from the royal Central Bank at the lowest interest rate, participate in the Royal Assembly, marry a member of the royal family, conscript people from lower fiefdoms, and appoint and dismiss lords of lower fiefdoms. These benefits were enumerated consecutively, one after another. Each one was powerful, and it couldn't be compared to the benefits given to a barony.

"With it, I, Queen Magentano, congratulate and bless Count Frontera. January Year 618. Declared by Queen Alicia Termina Magentano in the royal capital Magenta."

Flap! The scroll was closed, and the messenger smiled courteously.

"My sincere congratulations, Count Frontera."

"Oh, my sincere thanks to, I mean... Thank you."

Count Frontera was dazed by this whole situation. He remained in this state as the messenger congratulated him and when the maids and servants sent their wide cheers. Even when the news of the escalation spread all throughout the villages and when he was seated at the dinner table, Count Frontera wondered what had just happened. He simply was bewildered. It was as though his feet and mind were stepping on a cloud. It all felt unreal.

I am... a count?

Count Arcos lifted his spoon, feeling dazed. A scoop of mushroom soup went up, but it fell back on the plate. The baron blankly took another scoop of the soup.

I have never even dared to imagine this scenario.

He considered this an impossibility. Not in his lifetime. I mean, the count thought to himself, I had been suffering from crippling debt just the previous year.

“So we all must be alert from now on.”

“...”

“Excuse me, are you listening to me?”

“Huh?”

Count Frontera heard a voice, and he was jostled out of his trance. He then stared at Lloyd, who was looking at him across from the table. Lloyd chuckled faintly.

“I am sure that you are dazed, and all of this seems unreal. You are not alone,” said Lloyd.

“Yes, um, it is, indeed.”

“Yes, so you must stay alert from now on. That goes the same for me and everyone else.”

“What do you mean, Lloyd?” Count Frontera spoke, and Lloyd’s calm voice brought the same effect on him. He soon regained some calmness. Lloyd continued to speak.

“Because the intent behind raising our fiefdom to the status of a county is very clear.”

“By intent, do you mean Her Majesty’s?” asked the count.

“Yes.” Lloyd grinned. “The monster domino phenomenon destroyed many fiefdoms that sit in the eastern range, and as a result, the refugees flooded here. This means that she plans on designating this place to be in charge of reconstructing the region.”

“Hmm, I see...” said the count.

“We will be busy from now on.”

“I guess we will be.”

Count Frontera nodded his head, and it was indeed true as he listened to his son.

“Her Majesty has raised our status and entrusted us with equally heavy responsibilities. And this means that-”

“We can say goodbye to living a simple life as a noble in a rural province. Our influence has grown bigger.”

The smile on Lloyd’s face slightly turned bitter. Yes, an ascension to the status of a count called for celebration because it came with countless benefits and power. But the duties and responsibilities grew just as much. Their modest lifestyle as a provincial noble family was now gone.

Though we won’t wind up in treason or anything like that.

It would at least be so while Queen Magentano is on the throne because of the title Lloyd had: “The One who Carried the Magentano”.

The title was marked in the unofficial history of the kingdom. And I will be free from any form of suspicion of treason. In one word, this is awesome. The effect is applied throughout the kingdom, and it lasts until the queen steps off her throne.

The effect was a tremendous one. Lloyd even felt that this effect was the best and greatest he had among the other titles.

Since the worst thing to experience as a noble is to get involved in treason.

History proved so. It was also a common theme in historical TV series. Even the most powerful nobles and privileged were beheaded because they schemed treason. Even when the accusations were false and rumored, they were sentenced to a hanging.

It won’t be too different in this world, either.

In short, this effect that freed him from any form of accusation of treason was huge. It was especially so when the baron was receiving considerable attention after being promoted to a count.

“In relation to that, I suggest that we appropriately use our powers as our family status is raised and enjoy more authority,” suggested Lloyd.

“What do you mean by using our powers appropriately? Do you have anything special in mind?”

“Yes.”

“What is it?”

At the count’s question, Lloyd quickly gathered his thoughts. He regarded that it was appropriate for them to get a sweet taste of power now that his family status was raised.

“About Viscount Lacona,” said Lloyd.

“Viscount Lacona?”

“Yes.”

Viscount Lacona had a history of pestering Lloyd and his family, but he was retaliated against by Lloyd. And now, the viscount is paying the water bill. Lloyd decided to give the viscount a bitter taste of power. Thinking such, he smiled in satisfaction.

“Let us summon Viscount Lacona first thing tomorrow morning.”

***

The following morning rolled around. Viscount Lacona scrambled into the manor, his long mustache dancing as he ran. He had received a visit from a royal messenger the night before, and so he was aware that the baron was promoted as a count and that his viscounty now belonged to the county. The news was a bolt from the blue for Viscount Lacona, who was known for his wealth in the small province.

What...? Baron Frontera, that penniless good-for-nothing, became a count? And he’s my superior now?

Viscount Lacona wanted to dismiss it because it was too unbelievable and dumbfounding. But he had no choice but to swallow the bitter pill as the order came from the queen herself and came into effect as soon as it was declared. Knowing this very well, Viscount Lacona couldn't get a wink of sleep all night.

What's going to happen to me now?

His blanket normally felt fluffy and light in his hands, but now that he was gravely anxious, the blanket felt uncomfortable. It felt heavy, hot, and offensive. The same was true for his pillows and pajamas. Everything felt too uncomfortable.

Haah... Goodness, why did I do that...

Heavy sighs continued to escape from him without any end. He felt particularly guilty about the Frontera barony, and each time he sighed, a panorama of his evil deeds in the past spanned his head. Mortifying Baron Frontera had been part of his daily routine. There was also a time he insulted the baron in a ball. And just recently, he had stirred conflict over the Maritz Land and dared to contaminate the river that flows through the Frontera fiefdom.

What am I supposed to do now?

His future grew bleak with each passing second. He racked his brain, trying to come up with a solution through the night. What am I supposed to do now? He constantly asked. Grovel with a gift? Repent for his past misdeeds with a penitent heart? As the night crawled, he tossed and turned in his bed, his concern growing deeper. And when the morning came, someone from Frontera county arrived to announce that the count wished to see him.

Eeck!

His heart sank. The day had come. He threw on some clothes, darted to the county at lightning speed, and bowed before Arcos Frontera, who was now a count.

“Ehem. It has been a long while, Viscount Lacona,” said Count Frontera.

“M-my honor... to meet you, Your Excellency.”

“Are you uncomfortable?”

“Yes... Eh?”

“You are sweating a lot,” the count pointed out.

“N-no, it’s nothing. My clothes are just a bit too warm... Anyway, congratulations on your promotion, Your Excellency.”

“Hahaha. Thank you. In fact, I summoned you here because I wanted to be congratulated,” said the count.

“I-is that so?”

“Whew, of course not. I am merely pulling your leg.”

“I-I see! Ah, hahaha.”

The viscount was now on one knee, feigning a groveling smile at the count’s corny joke. Doing this made it more real. The loner and underdog among the nobles, Arcos Frontera, was now his superior. And this realization hit him harder when he was called to meet Lloyd in the latter’s office.

“Long time no see, viscount,” Lloyd announced.

“...”

“You have grown thinner, I see. Your color is off, and you now have dark circles under your eyes. Could it be that you have had trouble sleeping these days? My, should I sing a lullaby for you?” joked Lloyd.

“...”

“Oops. My greeting was too long, wasn’t it? Let us get right into business. Please,” said Lloyd, “over here.”

“Th-thank you.”

The viscount sat at the chair Lloyd suggested. He opened and closed his two hands under the table, and his back was ramrod straight, away from the chair. Lloyd noticed this and started to grin.

“Are you nervous, by any chance?” asked Lloyd.

“Not at all.”

“Please sit comfortably. I do not bite,” quipped Lloyd”

“...”

“Yes, just like that. At least your seat should be comfortable.”

Lloyd’s smile brightened. This only made the viscount more nervous. *At least my seat should be comfortable?* He asked himself. He wondered if that meant that the business that was about to reveal next would only make him uncomfortable. His hunch proved to be true three seconds later.

“Let me get right into business. I think the water bill needs to be increased,” Lloyd said frankly.

“Excuse me...?”

“Goodness. There is no need to be that surprised. The reason is actually simple. Have you noticed that winter will soon be arriving?”

“Y-yes,” said the viscount.

“Then, won’t the water in the water supply freeze as the temperature drops?”

“Yes.”

“That will burst the pipes, won’t it?”

“Yes, yes...”

“What happens if they burst? The clean water, which is used for the dye of the Laconata cloth, will not be supplied, right?”

“Indeed...”

“Therefore,” Lloyd went on, his voice gentle and soft, “I shall have to put extra care to ensure that the pipes will not freeze from the cold. We will continue to manage it. To do that, of course, what do we need? Yes, money. Won’t it obviously use money?”

“...”

“So all these efforts and endeavors are for you, viscount,” said Lloyd as he held up his two hands. “Just imagine it. Who suffers from the damage of a broken water supply? Who’s going to be the one crying? Should I turn a blind eye to it? No. I mean, consider our relationship. Your misfortune is mine, isn’t it?” said Lloyd.

“I-is that so...” murmured the viscount.

“Of course, it is. Thus, my point is that an increase in the water bill following maintenance is inevitable.”

“Then how much do you plan on increasing the-”

“I decided to be modest. I think thrice is good,” announced Lloyd.

“...”

Oh, you deranged thief!

The words almost slipped out of the viscount’s mouth. Lloyd or whatever he’s called was personified evil. He’s a devil, thought the viscount to himself. But he suppressed his raging emotions and exercised divine

patience. Clenching his fists hard under the table, Viscount Lacona asked, his voice growing diffident with every word.

“Th...rice?”

“It’s not much, isn’t it?”

“...”

“Right? Aren’t you relieved that the bill was not doubled but tripled, which is finally the reasonable cost of using my invention?”

“...”

“Viscount. I thought we had a good, close understanding of each other,” said Lloyd, smiling in a content manner. He couldn’t be any happier as he spotted the viscount’s face growing redder by the second. But he didn’t feel an iota of guilt as it wasn’t an unreasonable request or exercise of power. Not at all. It also wasn’t a retaliation against the viscount, who had a history of harassing his fiefdom. No.

This is just an extremely realistic measure.

The water bill hike wasn’t a simple emotional attack against the viscount. It was rather an objective decision born out of impartial and unprejudiced analysis. Lloyd made the decision based on the current reality of Frontera county.

We’re now exempted from tax, and the royal palace will keep funding us. But money will be spent to no end. We will continue needing it. I must do my very best to acquire capital.

The Lacona viscounty was now under his fiefdom, and yet, it wasn’t housing the refugees at all. In short, the viscounty was basking in the goodness of the Frontera county, which had protected the former from the monster herds and accommodated the refugees all by itself.

Like I would let that happen under my watch.

United efforts. I help, and you help. This was the principle Lloyd adhered to, so it was only natural for Viscount Lacona to shoulder the cost of housing the refugees. After all, the viscounty was now under the county. And so, what Lloyd did was the most pragmatic measure. Not only that, as far as he was concerned, the viscounty was financially doing good. So, raising the water bill thrice was manageable for them, though it could be burdensome.

“So,” Lloyd added, “I am thinking of ramping up the size of the civil engineering corp for my county. That is, by mostly selecting out of your forces.”

You can’t live in comfort. If I can’t, then you can’t either. I work my head off, and you should do so, too. No, you should work more laboriously than I do. That’s how I will be content. Just like that, Lloyd fired off his requests one after another, strictly adhering to the motto that you can’t be the only one lazing around in the goodness of life.

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Chapter 134: No Free Lunches (2)

“C-civil corp, Lord Lloyd?”

“Yes,” Lloyd answered, “You saw who they were, didn’t you?”

“Surely...”

He did. It was around the time Lloyd came here to install the water supply system. It was impressive to see that the corp was composed of seasoned engineers well-versed in civil engineering.

“Um, but why would you conscript my soldiers to expand your corp-”

“Why? Shouldn’t everyone take part in the disaster relief efforts?” asked Lloyd.

“...”

As soon as Viscount Lacona heard Lloyd’s words, he felt a lump in his throat as he realized what the former was saying.

“You mean...”

“Yes, you guessed it right,” agreed Lloyd, “your guess is indeed correct. Why do you think Frontera county has been designated as a special city directly under the control of the palace? Did you not think it is Her Majesty’s plan to designate our county as the central hub to overcome the monster domino situation?”

“...”

“Well, but if you don’t want to lend your hands in the reconstruction efforts, what can I do? But you see, I am starting to look forward to the first quarter report that’s coming up. I shall give a detailed report to Her Majesty about how you stand in strong opposition against the plan to rebuild the region,” drawled Lloyd.

“W-wait a minute, my lord, I didn't mean it that way...” defended Viscount Lacona.

“Well?”

“It’s just that...” the viscount muttered.

“Are you going to send your soldiers or not?”

“...”

Viscount Lacona felt stifled. Technically speaking, what Lloyd was doing wasn’t asking for support. It was a unilateral conscription, but the problem was that Lloyd had a crystal-clear reason for doing this.

The reconstruction effort was ordered by the queen. And the civil engineering corp is at the front of the project. So, if I show my unwillingness by refusing to take part and send my engineers...

Her Highness and the royalty would detest him to the hilt. In the worst-case scenario, he could be regarded as a traitor.

This boy is cunning enough to make me look so in her eyes. Yes, yes. It’s fully possible.

Viscount Lacona shuddered as he looked at Lloyd. Lloyd Frontera. He was an evil guy who had horns growing on his head. It was only obvious that Lloyd would paint him to look like the world’s greatest villain to the queen, and eventually, there would only be tragedy wherein he’d be helplessly thrown into the execution ground. At the prospect, Viscount Lacona was forced to nod.

“Yes, my lord,” acquiesced Viscount Lacona, “Then, how large do you need the troops to be...?”

“I shall leave it to your conscience and sincerity, viscount,” said Lloyd.

“...”

Please just kill me now. Just specify how many men you want from my force.

Viscount Lacona wanted to cry. When Lloyd saw the flustered expression on the viscount's face, he beamed. He knew that "anything" was the most troublesome answer. The same thing happened when someone asked another what they wanted to eat. And Lloyd did just that right now. He intentionally gave a vague answer, leaving the size of the dispatch crew up to the viscount's conscience and sincerity. Lloyd was certain that his answer would heavily burden the viscount. And he spoke something afterward to add another weight to the viscount's already troubled and burdened heart.

"Decide for yourself the scale of support as well," said Lloyd. "Then, submit a report by noon."

"A report...? And by noon, my Lord?"

"Yes," stated Lloyd.

"How many should I put in there-"

"I said, I will leave it up to you. I suppose it will depend on your conscience and sincerity. The number should be appropriate enough to keep this friendship of ours. Put the number that will not make me woeful. Got it?" asked Lloyd.

"..."

"Then, let's move to the next agenda."

Lloyd happily flipped the documents, revealing his plans to the viscount. These were mainly about the scope of assistance the viscount should provide to the county. They included the food and clothes for the refugees, logs and other materials needed for various constructions, and temporary recruitment of skilled workers. Although the plan was entitled "Plan for Support and Temporary Recruitment," in actuality, it was a unilateral order, and its rightful name was "Plan for Exploitation."

However, there was no way for Viscount Lacona to overturn the negotiation table and start a fight. He didn’t have any reason or capacity to resist Lloyd. He could only give a tired nod.

“Yes... My Lord.”

Viscount Lacona berated himself. He shouldn’t have led such an evil life. It was wrong of him to ignore and treat his neighboring lord badly just because he was poor. He felt a pang of bone-crushing regret, but the realization came much too late.

Of course. I have a principle of knocking my enemy dead without any mercy.

People didn’t change, so there was no reason to try. It was especially the case when someone acted with bad intent. Once you showed your weakness, they would stab you in the back again. Lloyd knew this from experience. He had learned this bitter lesson when he lived in his tiny rental room in South Korea.

The guy who used the room next to mine was a total douche.

It was around the time when Lloyd had just moved into the rental room. The room next to his was occupied by a nutcase. The guy was preparing for the civil servant exam, and he blared music every night. It wasn’t just loud. It was blaring, the noise coming out from the luggage-sized woofer speakers. *Boom. Boom. Boom.* The low cacophony hit the walls and floors and could be heard from Lloyd’s room. No, the vibration was so heavy that Lloyd could feel it from his bed, and a pair of cheap earplugs from a convenience store wasn’t enough to deafen the din. Unable to bear it any longer, Lloyd brought the matter to the manager. But it barely worked. The villain was quiet only for a day. The racket resumed the next day. Left with no patience, Lloyd eventually knocked on his neighbor’s door to confront the matter face-to-face. But to Lloyd’s dismay, he was punched in the face.

That guy was one heck of a weirdo.

The punch came so fast that Lloyd received the full blow. The world around him swirled, and his eye was bruised black. But before it could develop into a full-fledged fight, the manager came just in time to stop them. But Lloyd was dismayed and dumbfounded. He bawled that he would sue the guy for assault.

The color of that mongrel's face changed in a flash, and he started to beg me in tears.

The guy begged for mercy so pitifully that Lloyd believed that the guy realized his fault. The guy pleaded to Lloyd that he would be kicked out of the room if he paid the fine since he'd be out of money for rent. He implored him to let this slide and save his life. He was on his knees, tearing up.

The sight of him softened me.

Suddenly feeling inhumane, Lloyd made the terrible choice of forgiving the guy. But one month later, Lloyd regretted that he did as the woofer speaker came back again!

Crap. Thinking about it pisses me off to this day.

Lloyd felt his face burn as he dwelled on the past. Reflecting on the annoying experience reminded him that Viscount Lacona was the same as his former neighbor. Lloyd could forgive and tolerate the viscount once. But as soon as Lloyd showed any signs of weakness, the latter would stab him in the back. Strong against the weak, and weak against the strong. Lloyd knew who the viscount was. A groveler in the presence of the powerful. A devil in the presence of the weak. That was what Viscount Lacona was.

So, there will be no forgiveness.

Lloyd determined that he would gradually exploit and hang the viscount out to dry every chance he got. He will imprint a clear message in the latter's bones and souls that Lloyd was the superior being. Tilting his head, he stared at Viscount Lacona.

“Are you upset about the measures I have taken today?” asked Lloyd.

“N-no, my Lord,” said the viscount, his eyes trembling.

“Are you sure?”

“Yes...”

“I am very relieved. You are too generous,” answered Lloyd.

“T-thank you. Then, I shall leave now-”

“You’re leaving so soon?”

“Oh, yes, my Lord,” said the viscount.

“Hmm, that makes me a bit sad.”

“...”

“While you’re here, why don’t you put Sir Curno standing behind you in a duel against Javier. It would improve his skills and strengthen their friendship as they train. All these meetings and activities. It’s all to deepen our connections, isn’t it?” said Lloyd, his voice dripping with amusement.

Flinch! Sir Curno, who was silently standing behind the viscount, flinched, his shoulders trembling. This made the corners of Lloyd’s lips rise upward.

“Oh, didn’t you bring him with a diaper on? Then, I guess he can’t fight against Javier.”

“...”

“I am joking. Hahaha! You know it was a joke, right? I mean, it’s between us.”

“Ah, hahaha... Yes, it’s between us.”

One foolish move and he would die. Everything would be taken away. Viscount Lacona felt this in every fiber of his being as he noticed that not a single joy was held in Lloyd's eyes as he smiled.

Gulp.

Lloyd's gaze wasn't just chill, it was icy. Viscount Lacona was forced to put on a smile, but his face looked like he wanted to cry. The situation was at a standstill until he was allowed to leave the manor after a long while of currying favors with Lloyd.

"Whew."

Lloyd smiled in satisfaction after saying goodbye to the viscount.

Very good. I broke his spirit just enough. I also got a lot out of him.

The water bill jumped thrice, and the viscount promised his men to Lloyd's civil engineering corp and clothes and materials for the construction. All the resources were planned to be used to run the refugee camp and develop the fiefdom.

So, I have to start moving now.

It was time to move on to the next part of the plan. Lloyd took a box that sat in the corner of his office, and he made it for the refugee camp with Javier.

"Oh? Master Lloyd?"

A group of soldiers was getting ready to ration lunch, but they stopped when they saw Lloyd approaching. Lloyd waved his hand at them.

"Yes, it's me. Don't mind me. Continue what you're doing."

"..."

But there was no way that they could do that. In any workplace, the workers became busy at the appearance of their boss. They quickened their stirring with a ladle, and the soup and bread were served at a faster speed. The food

trays and spoons were laid on the table in a flash. Lloyd smiled wryly at the sight of this.

I kind of feel sorry.

The rationing soldiers hastened their work because Lloyd had shown up. Lloyd fully empathized with them because he, too, had undergone this before.

Especially in the military. The division commander and politicians really stirred things up in my base when they decided to visit us during the holidays.

Supposedly, Lloyd and his comrades should be left to enjoy the holiday and rest as much as they want, basking in the goodness of the national holiday. But when the higher-ups, such as division or corp commanders or politicians, came to visit, every single one of the soldiers was thrown to spotlessly clean the facilities in the base in gratitude for their visit. As such, they had to drop everything and work as they bid farewell to enjoying their holiday in peace.

I can't be as shameless as them. I should quickly finish my business and leave.

The soldiers were hurrying things unnecessarily. Lloyd pushed aside the apologetic feelings he had had for them for a while and looked around to do what he came here for. The place was jam-packed with refugees, who lined up to receive food. He walked over to them and hovered, which was enough to create a stir among them.

"Wait, isn't it him?"

"Who?"

"Well, who else? It's Master Lloyd. The son of the Count."

"Oh! Him?"

The man gazed at Lloyd as he pointed with his finger. He confirmed that it was indeed Master Lloyd. The murmuring spread further.

“It really is. It’s Master Lloyd. It’s really him.”

“From what I heard, he was the one who convinced the count to take us in here, right?”

“That’s what I heard, too. And this refugee camp was made by him as well.”

“And he’s the one who built the warm floor...”

Slowly, the line of people started to jumble, and they started to surround Lloyd. The murmuring started to develop into words of gratitude.

“It’s really him! Master Lloyd!”

“Thank you! You saved my son!”

“Same here! My family is safe and warm because of you! Thank you! Thank you so much!”

The clamor spread fast across the refugee camp. Those who were standing in the other rationing area started gathering closer. Soon, more than thousands of them gathered up to take a peek at Lloyd.

This is massive.

A sense of overwhelming awe gripped Javier, who was walking beside Lloyd. He had never seen anything like this. Thousands of people gathered and rushed to meet one person and thank him and promise to return the favor. Some came running bare feet. Some teared up. Some held Lloyd’s hands with their wrinkled hands. Each time, Lloyd returned every single one of them with a merciful smile and gaze. The sight was truly heartwarming. And so...

It looks like Master Lloyd has something up his sleeve.

Javier’s eyes narrowed, and his eyes held a glint of doubt. The Lloyd he knew would never put on a magnanimous smile for no reason.

He’s small-hearted. A miser. The worst kind there is.

It was true. Lloyd detested even the smallest of losses. The loss of a single coin or a button vouched for a few days of grumbling. As such, he was the worst kind of miser there was in the entire world.

Yet, he willfully accommodated thousands, tens of thousands of refugees. Did he do so because of the order from the queen? For the long-term prospect of them assimilating here? Sure, maybe. But given Master Lloyd’s personality... There has to be something more.

There was just no way for Lloyd to give up on all his hard work and effort even if the order had come from the queen and was beneficial in the long run. If Javier had to pick one person that was farthest away from being a philanthropist, he would confidently pick Lloyd.

And yet, he’s smiling and chuckling as he savors the gratitude of the refugees? When he’s the nastiest bastard here? No way.

Javier knew best as he closely watched how petty and sly that person was. There was something he wanted for sure. Thinking so, Javier narrowed his eyes and observed him. And later, his prediction became true when Lloyd fished a thick wad of papers from the box he had brought from his office.

“Yes, yes, thank you for gathering up here on your own. So, may I please have your attention? Will you please take a look at the contracts here?”

Flip. Flip. Lloyd waved the contracts toward the refugees, and an evil smile, terrible enough to make even the worst scrooges bashful, bloomed on Lloyd’s face.

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Chapter 135: No Free Lunches (3)

“Now, this is what you call a contract.”

Flip. Flip. Lloyd waved his hands, and the contracts fluttered in them. The gaze of the refugees darted toward them, and he continued to speak.

“What for? You might ask. Well, I won’t beat around the bush. I will be straightforward. It’s about the request to participate in the construction of the terraced rice fields in the eastern mountain range.”

“...”

Terraced rice fields in the mountain range? What? The name was long and complicated. Most refugees tilted their heads, and a wry smile formed on Lloyd’s face.

“I will call it the ‘Reclamation Participation Application’ for brevity.”

“...”

Aha. This enlightened them some more. The young master planned on reclaiming a land, so he brought a bundle of application papers. But why? The refugees looked at one another. Lloyd continued to speak.

“It’s for your sake. How so? By helping you get settled here. That way you won’t live forever in this crowded and narrow camp. You’ll be able to attain land for your family to make money off of and live again as decent human beings even after you move into the apartment complex,” explained Lloyd.

“...”

“I am sure that you don’t wish to live in this state forever,” said Lloyd.

Lloyd’s words, which were like a pebble, were hurled at them. The small pebble created a ripple in their hearts, and so they thought to themselves

that he was right. Actually, they were starting to get sick of living like a penniless beggar.

My life is worth more than this...

It was what the refugees were feeling in their hearts. They were currently reduced to living as refugees without any land or a proper house in their possession. And “refugee” was a flowery way to call them. They were actually beggars forever doomed to depend on the unilateral kindness of the Frontera fiefdom. Their bleak future was despairing as the majority of them knew who they were before coming here. Some of them were once landowners, while some were farmers who had worked together with their families. Some were woodcutters. Some were shepherds. Even though their lives were modest, they led a rewarding and industrious life and put their own food on the table. In short, none of them had been a beggar, dependent on a refugee camp, until they came here. And no one wanted to remain in such a state in the future too.

Of course. That’s human nature.

Lloyd knew that people would rather work and sweat while living in their own houses rather than live a lazy life in an organized tent that was filled with strangers. They would rather live happily under one roof with their families, and that wish was only natural.

I thought the same as well.

Just then, Lloyd recalled the time when he was in South Korea, particularly the time when he lost his parents and home. It was the most wretched juncture of his life.

I had nowhere to go.

At first, he lived off his friends, lodging in their rooms. He did so in the spirit of friendship but soon learned that it couldn’t last long. Though his friends said it was okay, he felt self-conscious around them and thought it couldn’t continue. So, he left his friend’s room to stay in the student club room. But he soon regretted that.

I was more self-conscious there.

As such, Lloyd worked his head off doing part-time jobs and saved up whatever he could. He then moved into a rental room. Although he was more physically exhausted, it gave him a bigger peace of heart.

What I needed was my own private space where I could be free. I suppose the same goes for the people here.

Once they had their own spaces, they wouldn't have to be extra careful around each other, and that would help their pride. Lloyd decided to take advantage of their psychology and turn it into an impetus for growth. And that plan was the reclamation project which Lloyd had just announced.

"It's simple. Just participate in the reclamation project, and those who work hard will receive a portion of the reclaimed land. That is, you will be able to farm and settle there. And my promise will be vouched in this contract," explained Lloyd.

Flap! Lloyd waved the contract again, setting up the table before the murmur died down.

"Okay, first come, first serve!" yelled Lloyd. "You might lose the opportunity to work if you're late!"

The words "First come, first serve" worked. These magical words brought about a powerful effect, and the refugees, who were drawn to them, started to sit at the table one after another.

"So, young master, I can work if I sign the paper here?" asked an applicant.

"Of course, you can," Lloyd answered with a smile.

"But what work would I do?"

"You will be participating in constructing terraced fields."

"By constructing, do you mean-"

“Shoveling, pickaxing, or scooping and moving dirt. Have you never shoveled before?”

“I have, and I’m used to it. You see, I spent my entire life messing with dirt.”

“Great,” said Lloyd. “The talent I was looking for.”

“I-is that so?” murmured the applicant.

“Of course. That’s why you should sign here.”

“Oh, yes.”

One contract was signed.

“Um... Can girls work, too?”

“Of course. Work doesn’t discriminate.”

“Then, I am in,” said the woman.

“What about your husband?”

“He hurt his back.”

“I see,” said Lloyd. “Must have been tough. Just sign here.”

Two contracts were signed”

“We brothers want to participate!”

“Um, I don’t think that’s possible,” denied Lloyd.

“Eh? Why not?”

“One person for every family. You see, I expect to receive a flood of applicants.”

“Then....”

“Wait, did you expect to earn a bigger piece of land if all of you participated in the project?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes...”

“Well, you thought wrong. What you can do is take turns among your brothers. Then, you will be able to earn the same amount of land for less work. Be satisfied with that for now,” suggested Lloyd as he looked at the paper.

“...”

“Don’t you like it?” Lloyd added as he looked up at the applicant.

“O-of course! I will do it.”

“Okay. Sign here.”

Three. Five. Ten. A hundred. A thousand. The signed contracts started to pile up, making Lloyd put on a content smile on his face.

Sweet. I like their reaction, and the contracts are progressing smoothly.

Lloyd was destined to house the refugees regardless of his will anyway. And they would be settled here eventually. Now, they were made to join the development of the reclaimed land naturally and legally. A win-win situation for everyone.

“Did you visit the camp to get these contracts signed?”

“Yeah, of course.”

On the way back to the refugee camp, Javier asked Lloyd as he carried a box loaded with contracts. Lloyd shrugged at the former’s question.

“There is no such thing as a free lunch anyway,” answered Lloyd.

“...”

“What? Why? What? Do you think that I’m sly?”

“No. However-”

“But?”

“Just for a second, I was relieved that you were born in a rural province like this.”

“Eh? What do you mean by that now?” asked Lloyd in confusion.

Lloyd turned around and faced Javier, who was putting on a mysterious smile on his face.

“If you were born in the capital, you would have become a terrible swindler,” stated Javier.

“...”

“Or a groveling disloyal subject.”

Lloyd was lost for words.

“Or a infamous swindler who cons people with his silver tongue.”

“Ha. Is that how you think of me?” said Lloyd with defiance in his voice.

“Yes.”

“This entire time?”

“Yes.”

“Dang. You didn’t even hesitate.”

“I am simply being honest.”

But soon, Javier grinned. He then uttered something that caught Lloyd by surprise.

“But I am relieved and thankful that you put your tricks to good use,” said Javier.

Lloyd didn’t say anything. He simply looked at Javier.

“Why are you making that face?” asked Javier.

“I am just figuring out whether what you said was an insult or a compliment.”

“It’s an insult for sure,” retorted Javier.

“I knew it was.” Lloyd snapped his fingers.

“Aren’t you going to lash out at me?”

“No, because I missed the timing. You know, it’s unseemly to get angry belatedly.”

“It was,” said Javier, “actually a compliment.”

“I don’t believe you.”

“Are you sure?”

“What, you want me to break into tears right now?” asked Lloyd.

“Please do hold back your tears. I do not think I can bear seeing it.”

“Right? I think so, too.”

A scoff escaped Lloyd. And the two walked side by side, and Lloyd thought about how the Frontera family used to suffer from crippling debt. The place had previously been nothing but a rural provincial fiefdom. But now, it was prospering. He wondered how much they had changed. Did we become

better people? Lloyd asked himself. But Lloyd and Javier didn’t have a way of knowing the answer.

***

The following morning rolled around, and Lloyd kickstarted the reclamation project. The first step, like always, was surveying.

Whew. The slope is steeper than I thought.

It was early morning, but Lloyd climbed the foot of the eastern mountain range after passing the coal mine. He headed to the land he would terrace, and he surveyed the slope, soil, and water in detail, leaving nothing behind.

The construction is going to be meticulous, but this place is the best option I have.

Some might inquire Lloyd about the rationale behind reclaiming the foot of the mountain. There were other lands in the fiefdom anyway. There were flat lands. Some might even cast doubt on his plan as if Lloyd was doing something beyond them. But the truth was that the Frontera fiefdom didn’t have much land left to reclaim on a massive scale.

The development in the south is already finished. Then, there’s the Maritz Land. As for the west... It’s not ours. Even if we’re now a county, we can’t touch the land outside the fiefdom without permission. It is possessed by Her Majesty.

It would be treason to reclaim land that wasn’t his. Of course, he wouldn’t be accused of being a traitor. But it warranted enough rebuke and scandal.

No need to take such a political risk. So that leaves me with the land in the north, but it’s not really suitable for agriculture.

Actually, Lloyd thought about reclaiming the land in the north, but he scrapped the plan when the apartment complex construction began. The soil there turned out to be worse than he expected.

It wasn’t conducive to farming. The land was only suitable for weeds.

So, in short, the only land left in his choice was the foot of the eastern mountain range. It was fertile and had long been accumulated with leaves and leaf mold. That was why cleaning up the trees and plants and flattening the land promised productivity. What was more, it wasn't owned by the royal palace even though it sat outside the fiefdom territory. As such, successfully developing this part of the land would grant Lloyd with bragging rights, in which he could confidently say that he expanded the queen's territory.

So this is the perfect place. I should also leave some of the lands in the fiefdom empty for later.

There were some undeveloped lands between the villages, and they were meant to be used either for residential or commercial districts. Lloyd had to save them up for the future of the fiefdom, where he would design the place based on the blueprint of the new city in South Korea. He surveyed the area with that in mind. Once it was finished, it was time to decide how to construct it. So Lloyd removed himself from the world for the next few days and remained alone in his bedroom, deeply thinking about it as he stared at the survey results.

Retaining walls. It's the crux of this reclamation project.

The foot of the mountain was steep, and Lloyd meant to create agricultural land there. He referred to the rice terrace that was common in Southeast Asia. But to his grief, he lacked knowledge of the terrace fields, so he couldn't follow it haphazardly.

I might as well do it my way. Okay. Just think of this as a large-scale construction of several consecutive retaining walls.

The retaining walls were found easily. In mountains and hills, concrete walls stood to prevent the earth from falling. They were common everywhere in mountain villages, highways, and national roads. But constructing it wasn't as simple as it looked.

The job of putting it up looks so simple because it's common. One may even think that it simply involves planting some walls on the ground. But it's not.

It’s never easy. One wrong calculation or fault in the construction, and the whole thing crumbles to pieces.

If it happened, the roads would be destroyed and houses would get buried. A landslide would occur. As such, the retaining walls required meticulous calculation and accurate construction.

But we can still do it. I just need to use my design skills.

The big terrace fields. And each vertical retaining wall would hold a large number of floors. He decided to construct a gabion.

That’s the best option we have.

If one drove through the national roads or highways in South Korea, some areas in the mountains were cut, wrapped in wire mesh, and filled with rocks. There was even a warning, “Falling Rocks.” That was one form of gabions.

Relatively, it’s simple to construct. I just need to create a wire mesh and throw thick pebbles and broken stones into them.

At first, Lloyd thought about constructing a general concrete retaining wall. But he couldn’t do so for two reasons.

The construction is happening in the middle of winter. It’s too cold. It’s going to freeze and melt for sure. The cement won’t be able to deposit properly. Plus, Bangul needs some rest. She’s been overusing her volcanic skill during our apartment complex construction.

Bangul was now thoroughly exhausted, and if Lloyd forced her to work and continue using the volcanic skill...

I can’t. It’s better that she rests for a while. Her butt is going to hurt otherwise.

Even though it was for work, she needed to give a rest to the breaking wind. So, Lloyd racked his brain for a new solution.

Wait... there's one more problem in building the gabion.

It was the material to be used for the wire mesh.

How about using wires? No. Bangul needs to rest. Metal bars? I've got nothing left. I'm barely meeting the demand for the apartment right now with what I have. Then, ropes? Nah. It won't do. It's too loose, and long exposure to the sun will make it soggy and weak.

Lloyd furrowed his brows hard. Nothing came to his mind.

Even if I use wires for the wire mesh, I'm faced with another issue. I need to gild it in iron. Otherwise, it's going to get rusty, and if that happens… It's going to crumble, tear, blow up, and the wall will topple down, hurting families and my fiefdom... No. I can't let that happen.

Actually, Lloyd could gild it in iron. But that would cost an arm and a leg. His finances were limited at the moment even with the funds received from the royal palace.

So let's just leave the iron gilding as a last resort. The best alternative is to find a cost-effective method or new material.

From then on, Lloyd spent all day trying to come up with a solution. What could be used to build a wire mesh for the gabion? Not wires gilded in iron. It was expensive. Lloyd needed something cheap, tenacious, robust, and free from erosion.

Think... Ugh. Think!

Lloyd deliberated. A day passed. Two days sped by. But even after three and four days passed by, Lloyd couldn't come up with anything suitable. At the dining table, he simply nibbled his food, and a ubiquitous furrow sat between his brows all day. The fantastical creatures, who always followed Lloyd, grew concerned.

"Ppo-do-dong? Ppodong?"

Unable to watch any longer, Ppodong decided to work up the courage and dared to give advice to Lloyd, who was deep in thought.

“Ppodong! Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!”

“What...? Are you suggesting that I pick a new friend?”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong nodded his round head zealously. Lloyd, who had his chin propped against the desk, turned his head toward Ppodong.

“Do you mean the random game?”

“Ppodong!”

“What? Are you saying that I should expect that a new friend will come out to solve my concern? Hoping that this new friend can create a robust material that can be used as wire mesh?”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“Hmm... I’m not so sure that would work,” sighed Lloyd.

“Ppodong?”

“Since it’s all random, no one knows what kind of a fantastical creature will come out.”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“Do you really think that it would give me exactly the one I want? I’m kind of skeptical about it.”

The Random Summon Game was really random. It was just as the name suggested.

“So what I’m saying is... We’ve been lucky all this time, but there’s no guarantee that we’ll be struck with another one.”

Lloyd chuckled and smiled, as this was the truth. He thought that it was all luck when he summoned Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang. But just then, Bangul, who was quietly watching the two talk, slithered forward.

“Bangul! Bba-bangul. Bangul!”

“What...? That’s not the case?”

“Bangul!”

Bangul nodded, and the three started talking in the order they were in.

“Hamamang? Hamang! Hamamang!”

“Ppodong! Ppo-do-dong!”

“Bangul!”

The fantastical creatures advised Lloyd as they stood side by side. Lloyd’s eyes widened as he listened to them.

“What...? I didn’t know there was a special way to affect the outcome of the game!”

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Chapter 136: Premium Random Game (1)

“What...? I didn’t know there was a special way to affect the outcome of the game!”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

The three fantastical creatures nodded their round heads. The three nodded so hard that their fat bellies shook. Lloyd rose suddenly, and fixing his posture, he spoke.

“Affect the probability? Wait, do you mean that I can up the chances of picking the fantastical creature I want?”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“...”

Their voices brimmed with confidence. Since these creatures never lied, their answer had to be true.

Oh, in that case… this is going to be very helpful.

Lloyd quickly did the math. Right now, he was deliberating about the material to be used for the wire mesh of the gabion retaining wall. But if a fantastical creature that could do the job came out, the problem would be solved. From any way he looked at it, it was a jackpot for Lloyd.

“Then,” said Lloyd expectantly, “can you tell me how I can do it?”

“Ppodong!” Ppodong beamed. “Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong! Ppo-do-dong!”

“Eh? I just have to desperately want it?” asked Lloyd.

“Ppodong!”

“...”

“Ppodong? Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong?”

“Okay,” said Lloyd, “so all I need to do is envision a fantastical creature with a certain power of my desire, and it’s going to affect the result of the game...”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong nodded again as he tapped his belly.

“Ppo-do-dong. Ppodong!”

Ppodong was saying that he was the proof, adding that it was the same case for Bangul and Hamang. Lloyd’s skepticism started to dwindle as he listened to the creatures.

Hmm... It sounds sensible.

Does my strong desire affect the outcome? It sounded absurd, but as Lloyd heard Ppodong’s words and his experience with the game, he realized that it could be true.

Truly, I’ve been very lucky.

Indeed he was. Ppodong. Bangul. Hamang. Each of them was summoned with skills Lloyd needed the most at the time.

When I needed to excavate the land, Ppodong came out. For tunnels, Bangul was summoned, and I got Hamang when I had to get rid of the water in the Maritz Wasteland.

Up until now, he simply considered himself lucky. A blessing and nothing more. Lloyd thought that he was being compensated for all the times he had lost the lottery back in South Korea. But it turned out that wasn't the case.

I wasn’t just lucky. What affected the chances of the game was my dire wish in my unconscious mind. The images I unconsciously drew in my head as I played the game.

Just then, Lloyd saw hope. He started to think that it was doable. He, thus, made a decision.

“Okay, I made up my mind,” said Lloyd as he flashed a big smile toward his three friends. “Let’s play the fourth round of the random game.”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

Lloyd’s words elated Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang. Ppodong brought out a welcome sign on his own while Bangul opened a tent. Hamang got ready to throw confetti in the air.

“Woah... Did you prepare for this all this time?” asked Lloyd.

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“To use it on the day a new friend arrives?”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“But I won’t be summoning here. We’re in the bedroom,” said Lloyd.

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“Okay, okay, hold on. Wait, to the training hall? Now?”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“Hey. We can’t go out now. Why don’t we wait until no one’s around?”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“It’s afternoon right now, so there’ll be a lot of people. People think that I summoned you all through magic. So, it’s best to be unseen when I play the game.”

It surely was the case. No one, including the count and countess, Javier, and people in the fiefdom, knew about the RP system. They all thought that Lloyd was a well-trained magician.

“So, let’s head to the training hall past midnight after putting Javier to sleep. Okay?” suggested Lloyd.

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“You know you can put them down for now.”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“But we have hours until it’s midnight,” pointed Lloyd.

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“...”

It dawned on Lloyd that they had waited for their new friend for a long time. Hours passed, and he headed down to the training hall under the moonlight. He imagined the capability of the fantastical creature in his head.

I want someone who can create wire mesh. Or someone who can create a material that can replace a wire mesh.

Lloyd tried his best to envision the image of the creature in all his earnestness. And he opened the random game menu.

Ding Dong.

[Random Summon Game]

[Spend RP to pick a summon.]

[A strong and unique summon partner will provide their unwavering loyalty along with a wide range of skills to their master.]

[Cost of the 4th Random Summon Game = 150 RP]

[Current RP: 4,783]

Okay. I have plenty of RP.

Lloyd had saved up the RP like the miser he was, never using it unless there was an emergency. Thanks to his spending habit, he was able to amass a whopping amount of about 5,000 RP.

[Would you like to start the random summon game?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a yes. Let's gooo!

There was no reason to hesitate. He selected "YES" as he thought about the capability of the fantastical creature.

[The random summon game is starting.]

Fwoosh! A blinding light appeared in the air, and it rotated as it engulfed the darkness. Lloyd stooped a little as he saw it. Relaxing his shoulders, he stared at the lump of light, and his posture looked like an outfielder waiting for the ball to come.

Something's going to burst out.

It was always the case. The blinding light would flash brightly, and a new fantastical creature would come out to his embrace as it shouted its name.

It'll probably be the same this time too.

Lloyd waited as he stared at the lump of light. He waited for the new fantastical creature to come out and land in his embrace. But...

Psh... Psh...

The light stopped rotating, and it grew hazy until it vanished. Nothing burst out of the light. In its stead, a message appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes.

Ding Dong.

[Sorry! Looks like you weren’t so lucky this time. Please look forward to the next game. <3]

“...”

Whoosh. The cold night air blew. No one spoke at length until Lloyd finally burst out in awkward laughter.

“Ahaha... It happens. I mean, it’s random. Don’t you think so?” uttered Lloyd.

“Ppo...dong!”

Ppodong smiled awkwardly as he put down the welcome sign. Lloyd pulled himself together.

That’s right. I mean, it’s random. So, it’s possible that I won’t win.

Yes, yes, indeed. Lloyd considered that he was just lucky all this time. He should not be too perturbed by this. Thinking so, he opened the menu to play the game again.

[Cost of the 5th Random Summon Game = 225 RP]

[Current RP: 4,633]

[Would you like to start the random summon game?]

[YES / NO]

Great. I’m not going to fail this time!

Lloyd’s determination grew stronger than before. It was fiercer, and he was more desperate. He conjured an image in his head and selected YES.

[The random summon game is starting.]

Fwoosh! A pale light appeared once again in the air, rotating hard and illuminating the area around it. Lloyd gulped dryly.

Please!

But his wish was in vain. The light grew faint until the terrible message appeared again in front of his eyes.

[Sorry again! Looks like you weren't so lucky this time. Please look forward to the next game. <3]

Whoosh.

An air of awkwardness hung in the air around them.

What the? Every fiber of his soul was disturbed. It was as if someone had decided to add pineapples to his pizza without asking. Total chaos. Lloyd muttered aloud.

"Hey."

"..."

"I thought earnest yearning would give me what I want."

"..."

Bangul quietly folded the welcome banner. Lloyd bit his lips hard.

Okay, stay calm. Stay calm.

He shouldn't be swayed. This was nothing but the result of random chance. Today was not his lucky day. He was just paying for the times he was lucky. So, the third try would work.

"Whew."

Lloyd collected his thoughts and decided to trust his fantastical creatures once more. There was just no way he would not win on the third try, he thought to himself. But when he tried out the third time with such determination, he was once again faced with an unbelievable message.

[So sorry again! It really is unfortunate. Please look forward to the next game. <3]

Whoooosh.

"..."

What was life? And why was reality so hard and harsh? Lloyd found himself crying, and he wondered why. Just then…

"Hamang!"

Hamang, a clueless fellow that he was, sprinkled confetti high in the air. Ppodong and Bangul lowered their necks as they saw him. Lloyd, who was wiping his tears, spoke.

"Everyone, drop."

"Ppo...! Bang! Ha!"

Drop!

No one was an exception. The fist-sized creatures stuck their heads into the sand in the training hall. Lloyd wiped his tears as he looked at them.

"Whew..."

He had struggled to save up the RP. So many accomplishments and achievements. He had to fight the strong impulse to use it. But now, three failures cost him a whopping 713 RP. And now, he only had 4,070 RP.

Woah. Is this for real?

Lloyd felt bitter and empty. He wondered if this was what it felt like to gamble all your fortune away and ruin your family.

"Tsk," Lloyd clicked his tongue. *Should I continue or not?*

Lloyd was skeptical. He considered the strong yearning affecting the outcome of the game a bogus, which suddenly made him grow diffident.

Maybe it's wise to stop here.

He could go on, but that didn't guarantee a win. It seemed only right to give up hope that he would be as lucky as he always had. What was more, the next try was the 7th one, which meant that it would cost him 507 RP.

If I try again and lose...

Then, his RP would be reduced to 3,563. If he lost his cool and tried again in anger, only to lose again...

The 8th try would probably cost me 760 RP. Then, I'll be left with 2,803 RP.

He would lose half of what he originally had. The mere thought of it terrorized him. No, he wouldn't consider it. By this point, he realized that the action he had to take was given.

I should stop right now. If I let my emotions get the better of me and keep trying, I'm going to lose both my RP and sanity.

Today wasn't his lucky day. As such, he had to make an objective judgment and behave rationally. Thinking so, he threw his gaze toward the random game menu and tried to close it. Just then...

Ding Dong.

There came a clear dinging sound, and an unexpected message popped in front of him.

[Accomplished a hidden condition: Three Consecutive Losses.]

Eh?

Lloyd wondered what it was. He then read the cascading messages.

[You have accomplished the hidden condition in the game, <Three Consecutive Failures>, by spending a certain amount of RP. As a reward, <Conditional and Selective Premium Random Game> has been activated.]

What the?

Lloyd's eyes widened. He started to process things fast. The power and image of the fantastical creature of his desire. And its effect on the outcome of the game. Ppodong's advice.

That was all true?

It appeared so, indeed.

"Everyone, rise," said Lloyd.

"Ppo! Bang! Ha!"

The three jumped to their feet.

"Ppodong?" asked Lloyd as he looked at them.

"Ppodong!"

"Wait, is that what you were referring to in the first place? The premium random game?"

"Ppodong!"

"Did you know this from the beginning?" asked Lloyd.

"Ppo-do-dong?"

"That you had to lose three times in a row to enable this function?"

"Ppodong!"

“Then... did you suggest that I do this in advance, knowing this would happen?”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

Ppodong nodded as though it was only obvious. At that moment, Lloyd became curious. Did Ppodong completely forget about the fact that he was being punished up until a second ago? Or was he forgiving Lloyd with a big heart? Ppodong was beaming, and his smile was so bright and shiny. Lloyd bit his lips without knowing.

And yet, I acted rashly.

He shouldn’t have taken it out on them. Lloyd felt apologetic, remembering that they wanted nothing but the best for him, and all they had was him. Penitent for being blinded by his own selfishness, Lloyd choked into tears.

You selfish bastard.

Lloyd wanted to slap himself. But Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang slowly approached him as though they saw what was happening in his heart. Rubbing the back of his hand, they comforted him.

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

“Um, yes, I should go with the premium random game since it’s going to work out well this time, right?”

“Ppodong! Bangul? Hamang!”

“Yes, thank you...”

Lloyd decided to keep his repentance deep inside his heart and trust his friends first. He once again opened the random summon game, and he noticed a new menu at the bottom.

[Premium Random Summon Game]

[You can amplify the chances of summoning the fantastical creature with your preferred power by investing slightly more RP.]

[Cost of a Conditional Random Summon Game = 800 RP]

[Current RP: 4,070]

[Would you like to start a conditional random summon game?]

[YES / NO]

Okay. It's a do-or-die situation.

He had gone this far. If he was doing it, he might as well do it right. Lloyd clenched his fist as he tapped the YES button. A new message appeared.

[Envision the power you wish the fantastical creature to own.]

Lloyd obeyed. He thought hard about the wire mesh to complete the gabion. He thought about the fantastical creature that would enable it.

Metal wire or rope that's robust and tenacious and unchanging. I want a fantastical creature that can give me that.

When he thought so...

[Your condition has been registered.]

Fwoosh! A brilliant light appeared along with the clear message, driving away the darkness under the moon. And it rotated violently until the outlines of a new fantastical creature appeared at last.

"Ggoming!"

In the light, there came a powerful and energetic shouting.

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Chapter 137: Premium Random Game (2)

“Ggoming!”

In the light, there came a powerful and energetic shouting. Something was coming out. Something was definitely coming out. Lloyd braced himself, trying hard to make out the outlines that started to appear in the light. At that moment...

“Ggomiming!”

Bzzzzzzt! A small lump burst out of the brilliant light and flew toward his direction to nestle in Lloyd’s arms.

“Ggoming!”

“Eh...?”

The first thing Lloyd noticed was fluffy white fur.

Soft hair? No, is it a feather?

This creature was divided into a head and body that was fully covered with white feathers. It started to flutter its small wings. Its head was as big as its head. Its beak was cute, and its eyes were dark.

“A parrotbill?” said Lloyd out loud.

“Ggoming!”

A parrotbill, which was smaller than a fist, replied as he looked up. He looked like a baby bird that opened his beak to his mother to be fed. Lloyd gulped dryly.

“Um, you see,” called Lloyd.

“Ggoming?”

“Your name is Ggoming, right?”

“Ggoming!”

“But tell me, what’s a parrotbill doing here?”

“Ggoming?”

“No, um, I’m not trying to say anything against you, but I actually wished for the one that emits tenacious and inflexible wires and ropes.”

Lloyd thought that he would naturally receive the one that fits the condition because he was allowed to add it to the premium game.

I was hoping it’d be something like a spider.

A strong spiderweb could sufficiently replace metal wires. That was the reason why he wished for a spider-shaped fantastical creature. But contrary to his wish, right now...

A bird?

At the emergence of the creature that had nothing to do with a spider, Lloyd’s heart sank as he wondered if the premium random game was another loss. As he thought about the amount of RP he consumed in the premium game, Lloyd felt as though bile was surging through his throat.

Argh, my RP. I spent 800 on this. I’ve worked so hard to save.

Lloyd was rewarded 700 RP after constructing the first apartment complex on the continent. Therefore, he had just consumed as much as the reward of his historical achievement.

Ha, no. No. He has to be useful one way or another.

Collecting his thoughts, Lloyd shook his head and told himself that it was too early to give up. Hamang was initially thought to be a failure until Lloyd learned what the latter was capable of. First thing first. He needed to check what this new friend could do.

“Do you have a note with you? The one that has done what you can do,” said Lloyd.

“Ggomiming? Ggoming!”

“You have it. Can you please show it to me?”

“Ggoming!”

Ggoming buried his beak into his chest and fished a stamp-sized note from his fluffy feathers. Lloyd took it and opened it. Just as Lloyd had expected, it was written in tiny letters. So, he concentrated on making out the words.

[Ggoming User Manual]

[Ggoming is a cute parrotbill. Please show him love and care.]

[Ggoming will give his utmost loyalty to you, his master. A summon partner is a lifetime pet and a family member. Please do not abandon him.]

[Ggoming can change his size by eating one of the enclosed sunflower seeds.]

[Red Sunflower Seed: Will make Ggoming grow to gigantic proportions. Effective for a maximum of 12 hours.]

[Blue Sunflower Seed: Will make Ggoming shrink back to a smaller size. Feed this to Ggoming before the 12-hour limit is up. Ggoming will be dehydrated if he stays over the 12-hour limit without eating the blue sunflower seed. He will automatically shrink back to his small size, but he will not be able to grow gigantic for the next 24 hours.]

[One set of the two colors of sunflower seeds is 1 RP.]

[Ggoming can use a wide range of skills while she is gigantic.]

[Bangul’s Skill Log]

[Spiderweb Discharge (Lv. 1)]

[Spiderweb Shooter (Lv. 1)]

[Nest Construction (Lv. 1)]

[Dung Blast (Lv. 1)]

What is this?

Lloyd cocked his head after reading the manual. He was confused because he noticed two skills that obviously stood out.

Constructing a nest and blasting dung... Well, he's a bird. But what are these two other skills? Spiderweb Discharge and Shooter? What are those doing here?

It was strange. Lloyd wondered if Ggoming could discharge spiderwebs instead of feces. He stared at Ggoming on his palm.

"Hey, Ggoming," called Lloyd.

"Ggoming!"

"I have something I want to ask you."

"Ggomiming!"

"How do you discharge spiderweb?"

"Ggoming? Ggomiming! Ggoming!"

Ggoming wheeled around for Lloyd to see. And at last, Lloyd noticed a small bag Ggoming was carrying behind his back, and it was spider shaped. Lloyd's eyebrow quirked up as he saw it.

"Hold on. Could that be..."

"Ggoming!"

“Does the spiderweb come out from that spider-looking bag?”

“Ggoming!”

“Are you serious?” asked Lloyd in disbelief.

“Ggoming!”

“The bag can’t be a part of you, can it?”

“Ggomiming!”

“...”

Ggoming shook his head hard, and Lloyd finally felt as though a ray of light was shining down on him.

Anyway, I am relieved. It’s a spiderweb. The game wasn’t a complete failure, after all!

Spiderweb. It was the ability that Lloyd wanted the most because he needed a robust and non-rusting wire mesh or wire to put up a gabion. Suppressing a large grin, Lloyd spoke.

“*Ehem!* Great. I need to test it out then,” said Lloyd.

“Ggoming?”

“That spiderweb of yours. I think I need to test its function.”

It was an obviously required process. This spiderweb was going to be used as a core material for the gabion. As such, Lloyd needed to see how much weight it could hold and how it reacted to varying temperatures and water. Therefore, testing and verifying its function in various circumstances was imperative.

“I need to create the design based on how robust the spiderweb is. Otherwise, it’s going to cause accidents. Retaining walls can lead to massive casualties if they collapse.”

That was the case as a retaining wall was built after cutting steep and sloped areas in the mountains. Underneath, most facilities were roads and houses. So, its collapse meant they would be buried under tons of dirt and rocks. A landslide would consume everything in its way.

“It’s the same here. I plan to build retaining walls that will hold the paddies and fields, which will be the labor sites of countless people. So, if that collapses and leads to a landslide, there will be a total catastrophe. Won’t it?” asked Lloyd.

Lloyd held out a red sunflower seed after finishing his explanation. But Ggoming reacted in a way that caught Lloyd by surprise.

“Ggoming...”

Ggoming refused to take the seed. Instead, he looked at the seed and Lloyd’s face, his gaze holding a glint of a complaint.

“Hmm? What’s wrong?”

“Ggomiming...”

“Don’t you like sunflower seeds?”

“Ggoming, Ggomiming.”

“Oh, are you saying it’s not that you don’t like it, but you just can’t be bothered right now?”

“Ggomiming! Ggoming! Ggomimiming! Ggoming!”

“Um, so you don’t want to work, and you can’t be bothered by anything in this world, huh? Are you asking me to leave you alone and let you live because you hate flying and growing giant because you just arrived here?”

“Ggoming!”

Ggoming nodded as he fluttered his small wings. Lloyd was flustered.

What is this lazy bird?

The fantastical creatures were summoned for labor. But this one didn't want to work, and instead, he wanted to live the rest of his life lazing around? Lloyd realized that contrary to his looks, this cute little bird was a terrible goldbrick.

Ugh. I can't let that happen. No way. No way.

How could anyone dare to stay jobless when the economy was bad, and employment was unstable? How could he dare say that he wanted to slack off when he had done nothing?

I can never let that slide.

Even the master, Lloyd, was working his head off every day. Even if he wanted to live the life of Riley, he couldn't. He wasn't able to even take a small break. And yet, here was this little bird that wished to be a couch potato. Resentment swelled over Lloyd.

And to think I had invested such a huge amount of RP in you!

Lloyd had spent a whopping 800 RP for the premium random game. But if he added the three times he didn't win, Ggoming had cost him 1,513 RP. And what? He wants to rest already?

It's like recruiting the highest-paying baseball or football athlete into the team, only to see him refuse to train or play games.

This couldn't be tolerated. Until Lloyd lived high on the hog first, these fantastical creatures could never be bums. Resolving such, Lloyd lifted his head and spoke to Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang, who were all watching the situation by his side.

"You guys?"

"Ppo? Bang? Ha?"

"Looks like our newbie needs to learn some lessons."

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

The three answered with force. They had been closely watching the conversation between Lloyd and the newbie, and they had let out a cry of disbelief at the sight of this newbie rejecting work as soon as he was summoned. The world has turned for the better, they said sarcastically. During their time, it was only courteous for them to gaze at Lloyd with a glimmer in their eyes. It was only virtuous to shout and beg at Lloyd to bestow any form of work on them. As such, they clicked their tongue in resentment at the unruly and ill-mannered fantastical creature. Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang approached Ggoming. Ppodong grabbed Ggoming’s shoulder.

“Ppo-do-dong? Ppodong?”

“Ggoming?”

“Ppodong? (Do you have a minute?)”

Ggoming nodded at Ppodong’s kind words. Just like that, Ggoming, who was in the dark about what was coming to him, followed his seniors to the corner of the training hall. Meanwhile, Lloyd gazed at the moon above. It was brilliantly shining.

“My, what a perfect day to teach a lesson,” uttered Lloyd.

Thwack! Wham! Chirp! Crash!

Later, Ggoming scrambled toward Lloyd’s side, his feathers plucked out here and there. He flew to Lloyd’s palm in one flutter of a wing and started to chirp aloud with a glimmer in his eyes.

“Ggoming!”

“Hmm? Wait, are you asking for work? You want to eat the red sunflower seed that badly?”

“Ggomiming! Ggoming!”

“Good choice. I suppose your older friends taught you how you should behave, right?”

“Ggoming!”

Ggoming opened his beak wide as his head bobbed. Lloyd held up the sunflower seed with a smile.

***

The test was a success. It was actually more than a success. The spiderweb Ggoming discharged turned out to be the best of the kind.

This is better than an actual spiderweb.

The spiderweb wasn’t a replica, even if it came from a bag. It was way sturdier and stronger. When Lloyd grabbed both ends and gave a hard tug, it neither tore nor extended. Lloyd activated the Asrahan Core Technique, rotating the mana circle by adding one each. He pulled the web with more force by harnessing the amplified mana until he used three circles. On top of that, he used the optional skill of the Asrahan skill, “Latent Power Surge.”

Ziiiiing!

In a split second, the mana amplification rate became stronger five times for the next 30 seconds.

“Arghhh!!!”

Lloyd consumed every bit of his strength, and the spiderweb stretched just a bit. It was sturdy and enduring just fine.

This is good enough. No, actually, it’s much better than I expected.

In nature, spiderwebs were the byword for thin and robust material. It boasted three times the tensile strength and elasticity of a similarly thick metal. What was more, the strength remained unchanged even after 20 or 30 years because of its excellent durability.

And it's strong against humidity. It hardly changes shape and remains sturdy even after prolonged exposure to sunlight.

And Ggoming's spiderweb seemed to be better than the one in nature. Moreover, it held one more advantage that was useful to the gabion construction.

It's sticky!

It was quite a fight for Lloyd to tear the spiderweb he had grabbed for the test. Since it was extremely difficult to tear with his strength, he had to scrape it off using a knife. But it still wasn't enough. Only when he smeared his hands with the bean oil was he able to clean his hands. Lloyd was amazed by the viscosity of the web.

And if I use it to make the gabion for the retaining wall, I'll be able to hold the rocks and dirt inside the retaining wall without fail.

When a mountain slope was cut, and a retaining wall was built, there would be a space left in between called the "backfill." The backfill was the area where the dirt and other sediments would go into. Acquiring stable bearing power was a critical issue when constructing a retaining wall. But now that Lloyd felt firsthand how amazingly sticky the spiderweb was, he figured the bearing power would remain steadfast even after a thousand years.

So, the gabion and the space inside the retaining wall will be sheeted with several layers of mesh made of spiderwebs. One layer of spiderweb mesh, and some dirt on the top. After, the mesh will be placed again, and then the dirt. The outcome will look like a stack of pancakes.

Lloyd decided to make use of the modern method common in constructing retaining walls: Mechanically Stabilized Earth (MSE). Among the methods, he judged to apply the HDPE geogrid.

I just need to combine the geogrid method and the gabion method. Combine the two, and connect with this spiderweb. And the structure will last for thousands, no, tens of thousands of years.

Crack! Lloyd cracked his knuckles, assuring himself that he could do it. He was skilled in design, and his fantastical creatures were powerful and skilled. Ggoming now joined the crew, and he can discharge spiderweb. And there was also the large workforce that was composed of Javier, Sir Bayern, the engineering corp, and refugees. Compound all of those together, and Lloyd will surely be able to create terraced paddies that can last from generation to generation in a great quality that will be registered as one of the world's heritages. Thinking so, Lloyd kickstarted the design, and as soon as it was done, he moved on to the construction. A rumor spread like a wildfire among the refugee workers. It was about how they had seen Master Lloyd, the young master of this fiefdom, freely mobilize fantastical creatures. A magical genius, they said. The voice of reverence toward Lloyd started to grow louder.

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Chapter 138: The Leader for the Weary (1)

“Hey, fellow over there. Did you hear it?”

“Hear what? What is it?”

“About the young master of this fiefdom.”

“Young master? Do you mean Master Lloyd?”

“Yes, him. I heard that he possesses powerful summon magic.”

“Is that true?”

The two talking were the refugee workers currently building the rice terrace at the east of the Frontera barony. One of the two motioned with his chin.

“There, do you see that?”

He pointed at Ppodong, who stood at the towering height of 32 feet. He was shaking his giant buttock, digging the ground.

“That giant mouse,” said the man, “I heard Master Lloyd summoned it.”

“Haha, he did?”

“That’s what I heard,” the man replied.

“Come on. That can’t be.”

“How so?” asked one of them.

“Just think about it,” another replied. “Just think how giant and strong that mouse is. His size alone tells how great he is.”

“Uh-huh, so?”

“His summoning magic has to be equally powerful to summon a creature of that size. But Master Lloyd barely looks 30,” the man argued.”

“Are you saying that it’s not possible for Master Lloyd to have not mastered the summoning magic of such caliber because he is still too young?”

“That’s my opinion,” confirmed the man.

“Then, how can you explain the mouse monster?”

“Master Lloyd must have picked a young monster in the eastern range and raised it.”

“I think you are off-base.”

“How so?”

“What kind of monster in this world grows gigantic by eating a seed only to shrink back again?”

“Are you drunk...?” said the incredulous man as he cocked his head to the side.

The man, who was asked whether he was drunk, chuckled and spoke.

“I saw it. I saw the young master feeding a red seed to the mouse. And the fist-sized mouse grew to become a huge monster.”

“Did you see it yourself? You?”

“Yes, I did! The others saw it, so you can ask around if you don’t believe me.”

“Haha. If that is true...”

“That young master is something.”

“Indeed.”

A host of rumors about Lloyd spread among the refugee workers. They were about how he could easily order the gigantic fantastical creatures and design such a large-scale construction. About Lloyd being a born genius in magic and how he can construct a building in the blink of an eye. About how he's a heaven-sent figure to deliver everyone from this disaster. All sorts of speculations, exaggerations, and imaginations about Lloyd compounded, leaving him at the center of the refugees' attention. Their reaction was understandable as Ppodong and Bangul grew gigantic simply after eating a sunflower seed. And there was also Hamang, who inflated to a giant size after drinking up a large volume of water, and Bibeong, who occasionally came down from the mountain to transfer heavy objects. And now, there was a new creature in the group: Ggoming.

Not even once did they imagine the existence of such creatures. They had never encountered these creatures in any book or legend until they started their work at the terrace construction site. The fantastical creatures worked with such force and dignity, and Lloyd was easily mastering over such breathtaking creatures. Everyone could not remain unsurprised. They were held in awe, and rightfully so. And as time passed by, there was a fierceness in the way the refugees behaved around Lloyd. The eyes of the workers on the construction site changed to that of the fangirling groupies who darted glimmering gazes at VTS.

However, Lloyd didn't correct the false rumors on purpose. No, in some sense, he rather encouraged them to be spread around.

"That's the power of one's reputation," said Lloyd, "So Ggoming."

"Ggoming?"

"Shall we fly higher?"

"Ggoming!"

Flap! Whoosh!

Ggoming replied as he fluttered hard with his 9.8-foot wings. It created a gust of powerful wind, and Lloyd was instantly taken in the air as Ggoming

flew high, about 50 yards off the ground.

“Whew.”

Lloyd clutched Ggoming’s back and wondered if this was what it felt like to ride the pirate ship in amusement parks without any safety device. It was dizzying but exhilarating at the same time. Lloyd lowered his head, enjoying the full speed of the flight. He looked down at the construction site that spanned below.

“Wah!!!”

There came a roaring shout from below. The workers, who were transferring the earth, were looking up. Lloyd waved at the men, and their cheer grew louder. He smiled contentedly as he eyed the men.

The people and their families will regard me as someone great and distinguished.

In actuality, he was a nobody. He just had a secret resource called RP, which he made smart use of. Add to that, he had read up on the Knight of Blood and Iron, which allowed him to predict a few things ahead of everyone. But the people were ignorant of it, and thus, considered Lloyd as someone important.

If that’s the case, I should reinforce their belief more.

That was the power of one’s reputation. Everyone felt it at least a couple of times throughout their daily lives. Its power was mysterious because it brought about different reactions even when two people did the same thing. One could be received with exclamation and admiration, while the other invited mockery. That was what reputation did, Lloyd thought to himself. He had an obscene share of such experiences.

I was treated as a nobody.

Poor. No house, and no family. Lived in a cramped rental room. Barely having any clothes, he spent the entire year with two or three faded

sweatshirts. He went to the cheapest barbershop every three or four months to save money. Dirty, ragged, and haggard facade and appearance. Stooped shoulders that have hunched as much as his small pride. Because of his unkempt appearance, he received terrible treatment anywhere he went. Every time he went to the convenience store for some food, a stationery store for a pen, or a barbershop, the employers and workers looked down on him so obviously that Lloyd could feel it in his bones. No, it was more than disdain.

One time, I was accused of being a burglar.

At that time, Lloyd teared up in resentment. But now, he could simply laugh it off.

That's why it's necessary to build up a good reputation. It doesn't matter if the impression is false. People put their faith in what they see, not in the truth. And that faith is what's going to help me in a critical moment."

That was why Lloyd flew around riding Ggoming. He inspected and checked the construction site in the air. What was more, there were practical benefits in doing this other than keeping up good appearances.

Woah. I didn't know it'd be this comfortable to inspect the construction site while flying.

Ggoming had grown to become 6.5 feet after eating the red sunflower seed. It couldn't be any more rejuvenating to fly on his back. It couldn't get any more comfortable as he surveyed the vast construction with one gaze.

This project is happening on a vast land, which is as extensive as the Maritz land.

But one thing differed from the Maritz land with its even ground. The land here was sloped and steep.

Goodness, just to think of climbing up and down the slope all day long. The thought of it just makes me sweat.

But thanks to Ggoming, his leg muscles were saved from exploding. But, of course, he had to go down and check things up close when he looked at the details.

“Ppodong,” called Lloyd.

“Ppodong?”

“This area you just dug today. I don’t think it’s leveled,” Lloyd pointed out.

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“I think you should dig a little more. And Group 16!”

“Yes!” answered the engineers.

“From here to there. Once Ppodong levels the ground, I want you to refine and flatten it with the shovels. You know how to do it, right?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes! Of course!”

Countless slopes were worked and touched according to the design. With a show of amazing strength and speed, Ppodong dug to form a stair-shaped mold. Afterward, the engineers were dispatched to level the surface of the earth, refining and polishing the dug areas. Meanwhile, the refugee workers transferred the earth Ppodong had dug to the foot of the mountain. And it was then left in the hands of Bibeong.

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

Bibeong was the strongest one among the fantastical creatures, but he wasn’t put to digging the steep mountain because of his massive 3,000-ton weight. There was a risk of collapse. So instead of digging, Bibeong was entrusted with another work: straining the massive loads of dirt through a sieve.

“Bibeong! Bibeo-beo-beong!”

Fwoosh! Bibeong grabbed a gigantic 32 x 49 sieve in his hands.

“Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

Rumble! Rumble! He shook the giant sieve hard, and the dirt started to separate from the rocks, small branches, and other particles. The dirt particles that were smaller than 0.7 inches fell to the ground, and it was to be used to fill up the backfill, the space in between the cut area of the mountain, and the gabion retaining wall.

This part of the job is crucial because how we fill up the backfill determines the stability and drainage of the entire retaining wall.

Lloyd made sure to inspect the dirt on a regular basis, and he mobilized Ggoming as well.

“Hey, Ggoming,” called Lloyd. “You know what to do, don’t you?”

“Ggoming?”

“Today, we’ll be building up a large and beautiful mesh. Okay, let’s go.”

“Ggoming!”

Ggoming flew in the air after eating the red sunflower seed. He flew across the sky, drawing an intricate grid using the spiderweb from his bag.

Fwoosh! The spiderweb was discharged out of the bag, dropping to the ground following his flight trajectory. It covered the ground after it fell. Just then, Lloyd shouted aloud.

“The White Cavalry! Your turn!”

“Yes!”

The White Cavalrymen, who were waiting with a shovel in each of their hands, started to get moving. Their shoveling was incomparably faster than ordinary soldiers. They scooped and sprayed the backfill material that had been strained by Bibeong. The backfill blanketed the spiderweb, and they pressed the earth with their feet. When the tramping was over, Lloyd shouted again.

“Ggoming! One more time!”

“Ggomiming!”

Swish!

Ggoming’s spiderweb intricately covered the pressed and flattened backfill material, and once that was done, the White Calvary proceeded to scoop and cover it with another layer of the backfill. This process was repeated several times. Ggoming flew and discharged the spiderweb. The lancers placed it on top of the backfill to be layered with another spiderweb mesh. The steep earth surface that was cut from the mountain slope was layered with ten sheets of equally thick spiderweb mesh and backfill. The outcome looked like a stack of ten pancakes.

Great. It’s going as planned.

The spiderweb mesh that sat in between the layers of the earth held the entire backfill together. Thanks to its powerful stickiness, the earth didn’t spill outward or below. It remained stable. Lloyd covered the gabion retaining wall in front of it. He then put up the spiderweb frame Ggoming had discharged. Next, he covered the front of the bevel, which was stacked up with backfill, with the frame. Then the engineers started to move. They poured the small and large pebbles and rocks he had prepared in advance.

“Okay, two, three! Pour!”

“Waahh!”

Rumble! Thwack!

The gabion was filled with a precise amount of rocks. And lastly, Lloyd tied the entire gabion and backfill with another layer of the spiderweb to hold it together. Thus, the first section of the retaining wall was finished.

Sweet. It’s going according to plan.

The corners of Lloyd’s lips pulled up in satisfaction. The engineers, White Cavalry lancers, and refugee workers perspired, and their beads of sweat

glimmered against the sunlight. From then on, the same construction process was repeated. They dug, pressed, sprinkled, stacked, pressed, and erected. The steep mountain slope slowly transformed into dozens of steps, each ensuring enough space for fields and paddies. The range started to widen progressively.

Sometimes, the weather was sleety. Sometimes, it was warm. There were also days when it snowed heavily and sharp, cold gusts of wind blew. But the construction never stopped. It was so as this construction was happening for themselves, not for others. This part of the land in the fiefdom was being reclaimed to ensure a new life for countless refugees. As such, everybody overcame the coldness of the winter through the labor of love. A day passed. Ten days passed. A month. Two. And finally, around the time the flowers started to bloom in the eastern range, everyone yelled aloud in excitement. It was early spring.

“Okay, the last one! You can do it!”

“Argh!!!”

“Two! Three! Pour!”

“Argh!!”

They poured the pebbles and rocks, filling the inside of the spiderweb gabion to the brim. The vast terrace was composed of hundreds and thousands of blocks, which required painstaking efforts to connect one another. And finally, the last block was erected to complete the picture.

However, Lloyd remained utterly calm. He didn’t rush to join the cheering crowd. He didn’t get carried away by the construction of the gabion retaining wall. The workers on the site were allowed to be joyful and excited. It was only natural as they were humans. But not Lloyd. Even when everyone jumped for joy, smiling and laughing at one another, Lloyd knew he should never let emotions get the best of him. After all, he was a supervisor who had to remain calm and act with aplomb. That was how he could prevent safety accidents.

“All right, listen up! Tell me, what’s the most important step of finishing up a construction project?” said Lloyd.

“Tidying up the site!”

“Accidents happen on what sites?” shouted Lloyd again.

“Untidy sites!”

“Got that? Now, it’s time to clean up. Let’s go!”

“Yes!”

The engineers had already internalized how Lloyd worked. They led the White Cavalry and the refugee workers to clean up the site and declutter the whole place. When the place was organized and spotlessly clean, everyone felt that the site was, at last, finished. But Lloyd didn’t join their cheer so easily.

It’s not over yet. I still have the last step to deal with.

The retaining walls were finished and constructed to endure the massive weight of the rice terraces. A sense of nervousness and reward rushed through Lloyd as he gazed at them. The following day, the day was murky, with dark clouds hanging in the eastern range. And it started to drizzle until it developed into a shower. It rained hard throughout the fiefdom. It was a seasonal spring rain that came every year. Lloyd’s eyes grew sharp as he gazed straight ahead.

Now, it’s time to test things out.

The last part of the construction. The safety check against the drainage and subsidence. The time was ripe to test its function.

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Chapter 139: The Leader for the Weary (2)

Swaaaa! There was a heavy downpour, countless raindrops soaking the eastern range and gathering in its slopes and valleys. They flowed down to the lower ground, that is, toward Frontera county, until it filled up the terraced fields.

Splash! For thousands, tens of thousands of years, the water current originally flowed through the natural slopes. But not this time. A man-made terraced terrain stood in its way, causing the water to fill up the areas reserved for paddies and fields and the backfill by a large volume. Then, it gushed out of the spaces between the gabion retaining wall.

Sweet!

Lloyd shouted inwardly as he busied around the site, rain soaking him. Each time, he activated the Subterranean Scanning to observe in real-time how the water drains out from the backfill. The result was highly satisfactory.

The water is successfully draining right now. The earth inside isn't running down, and it's neither tilting nor sinking. Wow. Is this real? I can't believe I made this.

Satisfaction swelled over Lloyd as he checked the result with his own eyes. He wondered what his university professor would say about it if the latter saw the finished output. He would be showered with praise, given an A+ grade, and dragged to study in graduate school.

"…"

Lloyd immediately jolted himself out of his trance by shaking his head to focus again. It was the rainy season now, so it served as the best opportunity to test the functions of the retaining walls against harsh conditions. Throughout the season, Lloyd continued to test and observe, and nothing fell or showed signs of collapse. In other words, the construction was perfection itself.

Okay, onto the next part.

Lloyd proceeded to the next step of his plan. Things weren't over just because the retaining wall was constructed. Now, it was time to distribute the land to the people.

"Please sign all of these," said Lloyd.

"These...? All of them...?"

"Yes."

Thud! Lloyd dropped a thick stack of documents on the desk, and its leg jerked with a noise. Count Frontera flinched and moved back before looking up in a daze, wondering whether the tower of papers could touch the ceiling.

"What is all of this?" asked Count Frontera.

Lloyd grinned and said, "These are the contracts and the construction attendance confirmation papers."

"Contracts? And attendance what...?"

"To explain it succinctly, it's the list of the refugee workers who volunteered for the terraced rice fields and the register of their working hours," explained Lloyd.

"..."

"I asked the workers to stamp the register every time they arrived at the site, had lunch or a snack, and at the end of the day when they left for home. That is, I asked all the refugee workers to do so."

"Wh-why?"

"It's my way of meticulously managing the project. And to avoid proxies," reasoned Lloyd.

“What do you mean, Lloyd?”

“Some may pretend they worked when they actually didn’t. It can easily happen in a disorderly site that’s poorly managed. Especially right now when they have the opportunity to receive shares of fields and paddies in return for their labor.”

Lloyd shrugged because it was true. From the beginning, he wrote the contract and promised that their hard work would be paid in the form of reclaimed lands. So he encouraged them to participate in the construction site as much as their stamina allowed them.

But not everybody is as hardworking as their employers think them to be.

No matter where you went, there were always people that worked their fingers to the bone and became a freeloader. Lloyd thought that would be no different here.

“So I paid special attention to managing the work register, ensuring that proxy attendance is impossible. And the outcome is this tower of papers,” explained Lloyd.

“Then... I should-”

“You just need to sign them, my lord.”

“...”

“I, Sir Asrahan, and Sir Bayern double-checked the contents prior. And we have sorted it out in the order of most hours worked.”

“...”

“We had to stay awake for three days straight to sort them. And compared to that, I’m only asking you to sign them.”

“...”

The count feared that this signing might break his wrist once it was done. But even though he let out a sigh, Count Frontera didn’t turn down Lloyd’s request because he knew more than anyone else how his son had broken his back to oversee and commandeer the construction.

He really did. It was hard to see him even during mealtimes.

Count Frontera had grown concerned that Lloyd was overworking himself and that the latter would faint as a result of it. Fearing that Lloyd might fall ill, the count wanted to help in any way he could. He put on his thinking cap, but nothing really came to mind. So, he decided that the best way to help his son was to quietly cheer on Lloyd and manage the refugee camps so that its operation wouldn’t affect the construction project. That was the best the count could do, and thus, he spent the entire winter doing so, and such determination remained the same today.

“I see. I see that you are right as I listen to you. You have worked so hard lately, and it would be shameful if I refused to help you out by refusing to sign this.”

“Haha. Right?”

“Indeed,” agreed the count.

“So, I ask that you finish it by tonight.”

“Eh...?”

“Thank you, my lord.”

Slam! Lloyd immediately ran out of the office after he was finished. The count was left alone and dumbfounded.

Creak. The desk leg jerked with noise once again, breaking the silence in the office. That night, the maids and servants went to bed as they heard the count grumble as he grabbed his right wrist and signed the papers through the night.

***

Lloyd’s plan was smooth sailing. In return for Count Frontera’s sacrifice of his wrist joint, the distribution of the reclaimed land took place in an easy manner.

“Okay, your total work hour is... Oh wow, you’re on the lead,” said Lloyd.

“Oh, I see,” said the man.

“Let’s see. You have more choices because of your total working hours. Why don’t you look here first?”

Flap! Lloyd opened a large map on the table. It was the map of the terraced fields, and Lloyd directed at several points on it.

“Here. And here. Here too. They’re not so elevated, so it will be easy to travel. The drainage is working very nicely as well, but more than that, look at the shape of the field. It’s perfectly squared, so it’ll be convenient for you to sow seeds, harvest, and manage the land.”

“Oh, then I will go with it, young master,” said the man.

“Here? Good. Here’s the contract. You remember how I told you to write your signature last time, right?”

“Of course, young master,” said the man, “thank you so much for your kindness!”

Prior to coming here, Lloyd had organized and sorted out the working hours and other details of every refugee worker that helped reclaim the mountain. The distribution of the land took place based on this data and noted contribution.

This is how it should be done. Of course.

The hard workers received good parts of the land, while those who worked perfunctorily got the corners and smaller areas. Naturally, some grumbled, but they were a small minority. Even those who received not-so-good lands accepted Lloyd’s distribution. After all, Lloyd had proof. He had kept the work register with a fine-tooth comb. On top of that, the awe-filled public

image Lloyd had promoted during the construction worked nicely to his benefit.

The young master is an incomparable genius. Not simply because he's a noble. He's just on his own level.

Such a public image of Lloyd was formed among the refugee workers. So even if the relatively poor lands were shared with them, most accepted it without complaint. It was Young Master Lloyd's decision, and it was beneficial to obey the results, they believed. Plus, they were acutely cognizant of their place. They had come here with nothing, so it was an act of great favor to give them a place to stay and work. Once the land distribution was finished, positive messages appeared to float in front of Lloyd's eyes.

Ding Dong!

[You have completed distributing the terraced fields in the Frontera fiefdom.]

[In this process, you have applied the retaining wall theory in real life for the first time on the continent. Your construction will be etched in the Lorasian history of civil engineering and present a new path for countless students.]

[You are now one of the ten most prominent civil engineers in the history of the continent.]

[Students of civil engineering will sigh and blame you for expanding the scope of their school tests.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 800 RP.]

[Current RP: 4,070]

Yes!

Lloyd clenched his fists as he read the message. But it wasn't because his name was going to be remembered in history. That was trivial. What thrilled him was the large amount of RP he was awarded.

800? Okay, I earned back the RP I used when I summoned Ggoming from the random game.

Although he didn't fully earn every RP he had lost, Lloyd was content with this reward. But that wasn't the end.

Ding Dong!

There came another dinging sound. At the same time, a series of new messages appeared.

[You have not only helped the refugees but also performed a great feat of successfully finishing a project, which will promote their independence and stability.]

[For this, tens of thousands of refugees are wildly cheering you.]

[You have earned a new title.]

[A new title <The Leader for the Weary> has been created.]

[The Leader for the Weary]

[Title Level: Fiefdom history]

I lost my home. I ran out of food. I didn't even have fire to warm me. I roamed without aim. Aha, this is how it ends for me. My tears and sighs were endless. I crawled, comforting my starving child. I wandered for a place to die. There was no paradise in sight. Not even somewhere to lie down. I gave up and despaired. Then, I met him. That was when I finally realized. Someone held out his hand to me. To me, who had given up on myself. I realized that there was one person left to save me.

[Compliment Effect: The refugees settled in Frontera county sincerely revere and look up to you. They will work the land in their utmost

capacity to pay off their debts. For the next 30 years, the terraced fields will have 300% more chances of a bumper crop. The crop will be raised by 200% on default.]

[Title Region: Frontera county.]

[Active Period of Title: 30 Years.]

[A title's powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region for which the compliment was given. Moreover, time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 3]

[Current CP: 108]

Wow.

The corners of Lloyd's lips rose to his ears after he read the message.

Now, this is what I'm talking about!

The chances of a good harvest would be increased by thrice, and the crop would double by default. Lloyd quickly did the math.

So, my crop will automatically double for the next 30 years. Considering the vast land mass of the terraced fields...

This was a jackpot, to say the least. The terraced fields were as vast as the Maritz land, but its yield was now double the latter's. And if there was a good harvest...

The yield crop would increase by six times.

This was a prime example of hitting the jackpot. To put it into perspective, it was the same as having a monthly income of 3,000 dollars to be doubled over the next 30 years.

Wow...

Lloyd now had one less problem to think about. With this amount of yield, he didn’t need to worry much about the refugees going forward in the future.

Actually, the supplies from the palace barely met my needs. But now, I don’t have to worry about food starting next year. No more reclamation from now on. Goodbye *to reclamation construction!*

Lloyd actually had been planning on expanding the range of the reclaimed land after observing the situation in the terraced fields. He figured that was how he could depend less on the palatial supplies and remain independent, which was especially crucial during emergencies. So, he prepared himself for the reclamation that would take place in the future. But now, thanks to the title he had just earned, he could scrap that plan. There was less work now, and Lloyd was closer to living high off the hog.

Argh...! I love it!

Lloyd threw himself on the bed, flailing his arms and legs wide in overwhelming joy that was so intense it made his face red. He didn’t give a hoot about his behavior as no one was around. And after a long while of basking in elation, he looked at the ceiling as he collected his breath. Soon, rationality was restored. And the first thing that came to his mind was...

Time for an interim inspection.

Out of the blue, Lloyd wanted to know if he was doing things right. He wanted to know whether pushing ahead with the status quo would be all right. He questioned whether it would be a good idea to look over his broader plan at this juncture.

Actually, something doesn’t feel right these days.

It was true. He couldn’t put his finger on this feeling. But it just came randomly. This weird feeling. Was it his cautious personality at work? Or stress? Maybe, he said but shook his head later.

No. The situation isn't all bright and positive right now. Right now, if I approach this situation objectively, I know that danger is present all around me.

Everything seemed to be flowing well on the outside. After all, the apartment complex was constructed without any issues, and the terraced fields were completed successfully. On top of that, he now had a new title that ensured massive crop yields. As such, everything looked perfect. But... what if something went wrong? What if he faced an unexpected problem?

It could affect the refugees settling here. Or the reclaimed land might not operate very well.

That could seriously hamper the development of the fiefdom. In the worst case, the entire fiefdom could crumble and fall apart.

The population here grew way too fast.

Frontera county developed so much that everything had to be perfect. Otherwise, one wrong thing could be a challenge to clean up.

Any failures will just hurt me. I might have to spend the rest of my life working my ass off to clean up the mess. Seriously, I shouldn't ignore this weird feeling that grips me at times these days.

It was rare that such a hunch was wrong.

It's something that we all develop after years and years of living and trying to survive. It's sort of like a big data file of life. I think this gut feeling is quite credible.

Lloyd deliberated for a while. And he reached a decision.

Let's use it. I'm going to use the Ending Spoiler.

Lloyd had quite a lot of CP anyway. He opened his skill window and selected the Ending Spoiler skill.

Ding Dong.

[Skill Name: Ending Spoiler]

[Skill Class: ???]

[Required CP: 40 (Second)]

[You can take a peek at the portion of the ending scene that will unfold in this story by spending some of the CP. It may have a happy or sad ending.]

The CP cost twice more than the first one, but Lloyd didn't care much about it. He selected the "Activate" button at the bottom of the skill window.

[Skill Name: Would you like to use the Ending Spoiler?]

[Current CP: 108]

[YES / NO]

Duh. YES.

[Skill Name: Ending Spoiler has been activated.]

[You have used 40 CP.]

[Current CP: 68]

Right after he tapped the yes button...

Crackle...!

Time gradually stopped around him. The tilting afternoon sunlight remained fixed and frozen, and the thick dust that came about after Lloyd's violent expression of joy halted midair. And a round and blue pathway appeared five steps ahead of him. Lloyd saw a milky area within it. He had experienced this before. Thus, maintaining composure, Lloyd started to move, and he stretched his hands into the milky area inside the portal.

Splash... Flash!

Everything turned blindingly white. Lloyd felt nauseated for a split second. He then slowly opened his eyes and saw the ending scene of this story. The end of the secret came into his view. Just then...

What is this...

Lloyd’s eyes enlarged in surprise when he saw it.

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Chapter 140: Second Ending Spoiler (1)

What is this...

Lloyd tried to open his eyes wide in surprise, but he couldn’t. His eyes didn’t move even though he willed them to. But it wasn’t just his eyes. It was his entire body as well. Suddenly, it became hard to breathe as if something heavy was pressed against his body. Searing heat rushed all over him at the same time, which was accompanied by a severe pang of dizziness.

Am I lying down?

His vision was hazier than usual, so Lloyd tried to make out his surroundings. Just then…

“Javier. It looks like… this is it for me.”

Lloyd’s mouth moved against his will. This Lloyd that was talking was his future self. His voice was coarse and exhausted and raspy.

What’s happening? What in the world is going on right now?

Lloyd’s heart sank. The words that just came out of his mouth seemed to suggest something ominous. His raspy voice, hot body temperature, and enervated body signaled that something was far from normal.

I think I contracted a disease.

It appeared so based on his observations.

I think I’m lying indoors. And judging from the blurry ceiling... Am I in a bedroom? The room looks somewhat organized though it’s not luxurious.

Future Lloyd was lying in such a place, gasping to breathe and suffering from a high fever. And he stammered when he talked.

I see what’s going on now. I’m saying my last words as I die from an illness.

Lloyd found his heart filling up with relief when he realized so.

Truly, this is the nicest and best ending there is for me. Though it's kind of uncomfortable that I'm seeing myself dying.

But Lloyd soon realized that he didn't have to make a big fuss out of it. The Ending Spoiler. After all, this skill allows Lloyd to catch a glimpse of how things would end for him. More than that, life always ended with death. No one lived forever. As such, he wasn't an exception.

Since I'm dying in my sickbed, it looks like I'm dying as an old man after enjoying decades of a sweet and good life.

Lloyd was relieved at the thought. So, he now observed the situation with more ease.

Well, let's just find out what disease kills me. I might then be able to prevent it. If I'm lucky, I might be able to have a couple more years of the good life.

This was the great thing about the Ending Spoiler. Lloyd concluded that this skill was incomparably better than TV programs that promote health and inform the viewers about diseases. The former allowed him to see how he dies and come up with the most personal disease prevention method possible. Lloyd was closely observing the situation when he heard a voice.

"No, Master Lloyd. Please bear a little more."

Someone came into Lloyd's hazy vision. From the direction and angle, Lloyd figured that it was someone who was taking care of him from the side chair.

I know this voice. It's Javier.

Lloyd's slightly blurry gaze moved to the side, and Javier's oval face and silver hair appeared in front of him in pieces like a mosaic.

Dang. He looks handsome even like this. How did he manage to keep that jawline all these years?

Lloyd suddenly grew envious when he saw Javier’s perfectly oval face. The latter’s voice, mixed with a groan, was heard just then.

“You can’t... You can’t leave me so soon.”

Javier’s voice dripped with sadness and anxiety. Lloyd felt his hand being grabbed. Javier was trembling.

This guy. Is he sad because I’m about to die?

Lloyd guessed that his teasing friendship with Javier lasted as they grew old together.

“Just hold on a little more. Please.”

Javier spoke, almost pleading. Lloyd suddenly felt Javier’s grip tighten. At the same time, warm and clean energy flowed into his body. It was mana.

Emergency treatment?

Lloyd was right about it. Javier was sending his mana to Lloyd, and it traveled from his hand through the elbow to reach his chest, expanding its range at every beat and driving away the murky energy in his system. At the same time, it continuously pressed on his heart. Lloyd realized what Javier was doing.

He’s massaging my heart.

It appeared as though this future Lloyd would draw his last breath anytime soon. Javier was striving hard to extend his life at all costs. Lloyd’s heart ached as he noticed how desperate Javier was.

“Master Lloyd. Please bear a little more. The physician will be here soon.”

“No, no,” said the future Lloyd. “Whew... It looks like it’s too late.”

“But Master Lloyd…”

Lloyd’s heart ached at the sight. But his future self was comforting Javier. Later, after some more difficult breathing, Lloyd felt his mouth open slowly once again, and he instantly knew what was coming.

I’m about to say my last words.

Javier kept massaging Lloyd’s heart, but the pain didn’t subside. Mere breathing agonized him terribly. Lloyd suddenly felt a drop in his energy. He had only a few seconds before his time was up. After some last words, he would be dead for good. Lloyd became nervous.

Let’s hear what I have to say.

His future self moved his lips, forming words through his lips and air. Lloyd focused every fiber of his consciousness to not miss a word of his will.

“Last year...”

The words came out with great difficulty.

“I shouldn’t have spent it like that...”

What? Last year? What happened last year?

“After I expanded the reclaimed land... I thought everything was going well. I let my guard down. The freezing cold... I wasn’t prepared for the epidemic... So, really, this is all on me...”

“Master Lloyd...” said Javier.

“The refugees who lived through the harsh winter... Whew... Me too... This spring...”

“No, no, Master Lloyd...” begged Javier.

“I’m sorry... At least… you should flee...”

Every bit of strength in Lloyd’s hand vanished, and it dropped from Javier’s grip. It hit the bed with a thud. And his heart stopped.

“Haah...”

His last breath. He felt like he was being lifted into the air. Lloyd’s hazy vision grew clear for a split second, and he wondered if this was a normal part of the process or death’s last thoughtful consideration. Then, thanks to clarity, Lloyd was granted a full, clear glimpse of Javier, who was tending Lloyd at his side. But it turned out that Javier wasn’t old.

Eh...?

Lloyd halted as he experienced his final moments.

What?

Lloyd wanted to rub his eyes hard. But he actually didn’t need to do that because Javier was already holding his tears as he gazed at Lloyd. But his face wasn’t old. It was young. Not just young, he looked as young as he last saw him. Lloyd’s heart sank to the bottom when a realization hit him.

Hold on. What the heck? Could it be that he stayed young because he’s a sword master? No, no way. Aging is natural even to the sword masters. Javier wasn’t an exception in the novel too.

If Lloyd died sick of old age, it was only natural that Javier was equally old and aged.

But he didn’t. He looks young. That means...

The period of his death he was currently glimpsing at wasn’t very far from the present.

Wait, I’m not dying of old age?

He hurriedly scanned his surroundings, wanting more confirmation. Lloyd then noticed his own hand that Javier was holding. The back of his hand. It was thin but had no wrinkles. No spots were frequently visible among the elderly. Though thin, the skin was sleek and smooth, like a young person’s. That was all the confirmation he needed”

Fwoosh! A blinding light enveloped him. Lloyd shut his eyes.

“...”

Creak. Lloyd was now sitting on a bedroom chair. It was where he had used the Ending Spoiler. But Lloyd didn’t notice what he was sitting on. Instead, he simply leaned forward, propped his elbows on his knees, and covered his mouth with his hands.

Gulp. Lloyd’s Adam’s apple bobbed visibly as he did so. But his eyes were trembling more visibly in fear.

Oh, my freaking gosh. What did I just see?

Thump! Thump! Thump!

His heart pounded and raced, and the tip of his fingers started to shake terribly.

I thought I was seeing myself die of old age.

But it wasn’t. It turned out that he was seeing the near future. Javier was young so was the back of his own hand. There wasn’t any trace of aging.

This is nuts… This is nuts!!

A pang of terror gripped him by instinct. But it came with a sense of relief that he had made the right choice to check the ending. Two contrasting emotions swirled in him. His hair stood in fright.

Haah... Calm down first.

Lloyd sighed at length. He told himself that he wasn’t dying right now. He had in advance caught a glimpse of the future at least for a short while. The situation could definitely be avoided. Thinking such, Lloyd collected his thoughts. His pounding heart and raspy breathing soon found composure.

“Woah. This is nuts.”

Lloyd shook his head and chuckled. He was now calm. The ending scenes started to appear in his head one by one. Afterward, he was able to pick up a few things after coldly observing them.

Some pointers. I died. Died of disease. And this happened in the near future.

A few years later? Or a few months? Lloyd coolly analyzed his last words. And he was able to infer the time period of his death.

Next spring. I'm sure of it.

He had several clues.

I said that I let my guard down after expanding the reclaimed land the previous year. And I mentioned the harsh weather. So, this year's construction of the reclaimed land becomes the previous year. In other words, this winter is going to be freezing cold.

It appeared so, indeed.

And what I said last really backs it all up. I said that the same thing happened to me in the spring.

A vague picture was drawn as he gathered his thoughts. The construction of the retaining walls and reclaimed land. The unprecedented cold in the winter. The epidemic in the following spring. Then, his death.

The problem is that I'm dying because of an epidemic.

Lloyd clearly heard his last words, how he had failed to prepare against the epidemic. And it was all on him.

The fiefdom will be struck with an epidemic. Countless refugees will perish, and I will too along with them.

What happens after? What happens to Javier? There was no way of knowing that far.

Maybe he makes a tomb for me and leaves the fiefdom to start another adventure of his own. Just like how the Knight of Blood and Iron went in the very beginning.

If that were to happen, he would take a similar path in the story, just like in the novel. Lloyd wrinkled his nose at the irony.

Well, I don't have to mind that far.

There was a bigger fish to fry. The first thing he had to attend to was the prevention of the epidemic that was expected to come next spring.

Whew... I thought I could finally rest at ease after the reclamation project ended in great success.

But right now, his survival was dependent on whether he stopped the epidemic or not. From then on, Lloyd racked his brain, trying his best to speculate the origin of the epidemic through several clues he had earned from the spoiler. But there was one problem.

I know too little.

Lloyd couldn't think of anything. He had no way of knowing what kind of epidemic would hit the fiefdom or how it would happen. And so, he was troubled.

Maybe it happens because of the incoming flood of refugees? Possibly. But what if my guess is wrong? What if I work to prevent the event from happening only for the actual source to be from somewhere unexpected?

If that was the case, the ending he had just seen would actualize. He would fall ill at a young age and die without having been able to enjoy life. There was nothing more miserable and unfair than that.

No. A vague and general response won't prevent anything.

What Lloyd needed was a detailed preparation and response that was accurate, smart, and straightforward. To that end, he had to figure out the exact origin of the epidemic and infection route. And so, Lloyd thought

about using the Ending Spoiler again, getting more observations and clues. But it was impossible.

The Ending Spoiler costs 80 CP since this would be my third try. Goodness, how the price jumps!

The second try had cost him 40 CP. It appeared that the price doubled each time he used it. Right now, he only had 60 CP in his pocket.

Haah... What then? How did that epidemic spread?

Lloyd agonized over it, cooped up in his room for half a day. The night came, and Javier visited.

“I came to pick you up since you didn’t come when it was time,” said Javier.

“What?”

“The time for a lullaby,” answered Javier.

“...”

Oh, right. I forgot about that.

Lloyd was supposed to sing a lullaby to this boy every night at this hour. But he was so preoccupied that he missed the time. Lloyd smiled wryly.

“Tsk,” said Lloyd, “Is that why you cried? Because you can’t hear my lullaby anymore?”

“Cry...? What do you mean?”

“You cried, I mean. At the ending.”

“Ending?” asked Javier again.

“There’s something like that.”

Lloyd shrugged and got up from his seat. The hours of deliberation had tensed his muscles. His head felt heavy. So, he decided to take a stroll and get some fresh air since he needed to put Javier to sleep anyway.

A new idea or clue might come up. Who knows?

Lloyd stepped out with Javier, and the two walked toward his quarter without any words.

“By the way,” Javier said as he broke the silence. It looked like something just came to his mind. “I forgot to report something to you this afternoon.”

“Report what to me? What is it?”

“It’s about the human waste at the camps,” said Javier.

“Yeah, what about it?”

“The pit we had dug previously is filled to the brim.”

“Already?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Hmm... I see. After all, there are a lot of people.”

Lloyd tilted his head. The refugee camps housed tens of thousands of refugees, and the number of feces and urines they excreted was unimaginable. Lloyd had instructed them not to dump those anywhere as they pleased. A specific hole was dug for that purpose, but now, it was already filled. Lloyd started to get a headache.

The future epidemic is already giving me a headache, and now this. Maybe I should make their meals smaller. That might make them go less. No, that’s too harsh. Dig more holes? Hmm... That seems like a superficial solution.

Since there were tens of thousands of people, the amount of waste produced was unimaginably large. There was a ridiculous amount left over even after using what they could as fertilizer.

There is a clear limit to disposing of them in the ground. Or should I just toss them into the Prona River? The northern downstream isn't touching the fiefdom anyway. It's a deserted land. That might be the easiest and cleanest way. Wait a minute.

As Lloyd continued his train of thought, something, an idea flashed across his mind. Lloyd stopped dead in his tracks. His head started to spin fast. Clues came to his mind. One by one, piece by piece, they started to gather and become whole. They connected until it vaguely formed a picture.

Epidemic... Feces and urine... River... Harsh winter... Spring... And epidemic.

The cause of the epidemic. And the feces and urine issue Javier just mentioned. Those two pieces of the puzzle were put together, finally enlightening Lloyd of the clue. This clue was something that actually took place on earth before.

"Winter of 1830. Vienna, Austria. Unprecedented cold. The freezing of the Danube River. And... cholera."

Lloyd clenched his fists. Finally, he found out the cause of the epidemic.

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Chapter 141: Second Ending Spoiler (2)

“Winter of 1830. Vienna, Austria. Freezing winter. The freezing of the River Danube. And... cholera.”

Lloyd clenched his fists as the puzzle was completed in his head. And the answer was revealed.

Yes. That was it.

Lloyd gulped involuntarily, and Javier, who was beside him, cocked his head to the side.

“What is cholera?” asked Javier.

“Hmm?”

“You just murmured some things to yourself. Vienna, Austria. Danube River. Cholera. I think that’s what I heard.”

“Oh, those?” said Lloyd.

Lloyd had unconsciously murmured after his realization, but Javier must have heard him with his sensitive hearing. Lloyd smirked and quickly gave a vague answer.

“Those are the names of a long-forgotten ancient city and river,” said Lloyd.

“Ancient city?”

“Yeah, I came across the names in a book I read when I visited the academy to visit Julian.”

“But why are you saying them now-”

“Since it just dawned on me,” Lloyd explained, “that the situation of that city is akin to ours.”

“How so?”

“We both have an overcrowding issue.”

Thinking about it, he was right. Vienna of 1830 and Frontera fiefdom held similarities that went beyond their differing dimension and location.

They didn’t have any decent facility to manage bodily waste. But the city experienced a sudden increase in population.

In 1830, Europe was going through changes following the Industrial Revolution. Countless workers flooded into the city, and one of the cities that people moved to was Vienna, the capital of Austria. The deluge of workers led to a sharp increase in population in the city, posing a severe problem in managing human waste.

Duh. Prior to that, bodily waste was mainly used as fertilizers, and the rest was tossed in a river or on the streets. But when the population underwent a drastic change, such a method of disposing of waste didn’t work anymore.

Despite such a problem at hand, nobody came up with any measure, and winter arrived. Moreover, that winter was unprecedentedly cold, freezing the entire Danube River that cut across the city district of Vienna. But people didn’t mind at all. They innocently went on their usual way of dumping bodily waste into the river just like they had always done.

That was the start of the plague.

Originally, those massive amounts of human waste should have flowed along the river current and naturally decomposed by the host of microorganisms underwater. However, the Danube River froze up in winter, and that completely changed things. The waste didn’t flow down. It accumulated in the river, only to melt under the sun in the afternoon and freeze again at night, rotting in the process. Just like that, a large amount of rotten waste smeared deep into the earth, eventually contaminating the underground water in the area. The following spring, people who drank the water contracted cholera. The beginning of a large-scale epidemic plagued the whole city.

A similar thing is going to happen here soon. And the aftermath is what I had seen in the Ending Spoiler.

Lloyd realized what was happening. The Danube River froze, and the aftermath was the cholera outbreak. Lloyd modified some parts of the history and narrated it to Javier.

“I saw the record of how many people died in such fashion.”

“In an ancient city called Vienna?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, I believe the same thing could happen to us.”

Lloyd was certain about it. The situation here wasn’t much different. Vienna saw a wave of workers arrive following its industrialization. Here, refugees took shelter in this fiefdom due to the monster domino effect.

“Plus, we don’t have any waste disposal facility either. Just imagine what would happen if the upcoming winter is colder than expected and freezes the Prona River. The catastrophe that the ancient city went through will be repeated here, and the chances of it happening are very high.”

There was a force in Lloyd’s voice. The more he spoke, the greater his conviction became. He had seen how the infectious disease perished him through the Ending Spoiler. The future Lloyd had made a wrong decision at this point in time. He must not have come up with a proper waste treatment system in place and opted for the convenient way of doing things, which was dumping the waste in the Prona River. Now, Lloyd was able to wrap his head around what had happened. The situation was becoming clear and making sense to Lloyd. But not to Javier, who cocked his head to the side.

“Listening to your words, I come to think that it indeed may be the case. However, what is a waste treatment facility?”

“Hmm?”

“Is there a way better than digging a hole?”

“Yeah. Of course.”

Lloyd nodded. Javier clamped his mouth shut as he noticed how confident he was.

“...”

Truly, this young master was weird. No, he was marvelous. Javier’s mind flew back to the afternoon.

I visited Master Lloyd to report something to him.

Javier had knocked at his doors, but there was no answer. But he did feel Lloyd’s presence inside. And since the report was to be given, Javier carefully opened the door and entered the bedroom to make sure that Lloyd would not be disrupted. When he did, he was shocked.

I couldn’t find him anywhere.

Lloyd was nowhere to be seen. He was gone. Javier searched every corner of the room, the table, under the bed, behind the curtain... He checked every possible spot Lloyd could have hidden, but it was in vain. The funny thing, however, was that he was able to feel the latter’s presence in the room.

I never experienced anything like it before.

Javier rummaged through the bedroom, but Lloyd was nowhere to be found. It was an inexplicable mystery to Javier, and all the more so because he was a sword master.

There is no way Master Lloyd can fool my senses.

Javier was right about it. And yet, Lloyd was nowhere to be seen or discovered. It was as though Lloyd had become a ghost whose presence could be felt but not seen. Javier was flustered, so he left the bedroom, deciding to take care of other businesses that he was behind with. But when he returned later that night, Javier found Lloyd lazing around in bed as usual.

“...”

As he saw Lloyd, Javier wondered what had happened in the afternoon in this bedroom. He was curious what kind of trickery his young master resorted to disturb his senses. But there was no way of knowing. Even the abilities and knowledge Lloyd owned were beyond Javier.

Should I... doubt him? Or should I just be curious?

Javier wondered for a second, but the answer was simple.

I should just keep watching him for now with curiosity, nothing else.

The more Javier closely watched Lloyd beside him, he became more confident that something was going on with his young master. It must have been from the day Lloyd had constructed an ondol facility for the bar owner. Lloyd became a completely different person overnight. But Javier didn't want to grow suspicious of him just because of that. Even if the latter held a secret and mysterious power, Lloyd gave every bit of himself to develop the fiefdom, devote himself to people around him, and save his family and countless others from destruction. Therefore, right now, Javier should merely remain curious. He should stop there without probing any further.

That's my mission.

Javier chuckled. He was nothing but a loyal knight who pledged allegiance to the lord. So as long as Lloyd spent his efforts to develop the fiefdom, Javier had to do his best to protect this young master.

"Understood... Shall we go back to your quarters?" suggested Javier.

"Eh? Why?"

"Aren't you planning on a new project?"

"You are right, but..."

"You will be up all night, thinking and planning, won't you?" asked Javier.

"Probably?"

“That is why-”

“You will be keeping me company?” interrupted Lloyd.

“Yes. I will protect you,” answered Javier.

“What are you saying? You’re creeping me out.”

“…”

“Whew. That gave me goosebumps.”

“…”

“What, you will be loyal by working with me through the night?”

“Yes.”

“If you want, then by all means.”

“…”

“Let’s grab some midnight snacks then.”

A grin formed on Lloyd’s face. He had a lot of things to work on tonight. And just like that, the night of late work wore on.

***

The following morning, Lloyd revealed his plan to Count Frontera.

“What is that Lloyd? A large-scale sewage?” asked the count.

“Yes, my lord.”

“What is that?”

“It’s an underground tunnel that takes care of human waste,” explained Lloyd.

They were having breakfast. Nutty cheese, and fresh salad. Eggs and juicy sausages. All with a glass of warm milk, the meal was bountiful. Lloyd glanced at the table and spoke carefully.

“Hmm, if you wish me to discuss this project after we eat, I can come back next time,” said Lloyd.

“Not at all. I am fine.”

The subject of feces and urines truly didn’t suit the aromatic meal. Most would have furrowed their eyes, but not Count Frontera. He rather chuckled in amusement.

“It pertains to my fiefdom and the people living here,” answered the count, “and judging from your careful facial expression, I reckon that it is more significant than breakfast.”

“Thank you for understanding,” said Lloyd.

“So, a way to dispose of waste? I believe you brought it up because there is a need for it?”

“Certainly,” said Lloyd.

“Could you explain it to me?”

“Yes.”

From then on, Lloyd proceeded to narrate the same story he had shared with Javier the previous day to the count. As the story progressed, the count’s face darkened.

“Can infectious disease really happen in such fashion?”

“Yes. It appears so. It’s a fact recorded in history.”

“Then, are you suggesting that a similar thing can happen in the fiefdom?”

“It is likely,” said Lloyd.

“And that is why we need a large-scale sewage system?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded, for it was his conclusion. At first, he thought about dumping the waste in a place far away from the fiefdom. But there wasn’t a suitable location for that. The east had a mountain range, and disposing of the waste there could contaminate the underground water and water supply system. Dumping in the south, Lacona viscounty, was equally problematic.

And the outbreak there will eventually spread to our fiefdom in no time.

The west was out of the option, too, because it belonged to the palace. That left Lloyd with the north, but the mere thought of dumping massive waste there stifled him. The reason was simple.

There is just too much waste.

Honestly, it wasn’t rocket science. Considering that each individual let out about 7 ounces a day...

Multiply that by the number of refugees, and it’s about 9 to 10 tons of waste every day. A month, and it’d reach about 300 tons.

300 tons of human dung in just one month. 3,600 tons in one year. In ten years, the amount would be...

Tsk. Let’s stop here.

His stomach churned in nausea as he imagined it. Anyway, whatever means Lloyd would employ to transfer the waste, be it by carrying it in buckets or carts, the sheer amount of it would make it difficult to transport. Moreover, the Frontera fiefdom never saw its population grow over thousands before the arrival of the refugees, so it wasn’t like Cremo city and the royal palace, whose systems and infrastructure were well-established. So, Lloyd decided to refer to a similar case to deal with the waste disposal issue.

So I must refer to Vienna, Austria. The method they employed will help me greatly.

Lloyd made up his mind to set the Viennese case as his role model. He would figure out a way to prevent the fiefdom from being plagued by an infectious disease, and referring to Austria's response to their situation showed him the solution to their own.

From 1830 to 1835, the city built 4.9 x 6.5 feet sewers parallel to the River Wien. What was it called? Cholera Canal?

There was more.

Later, from 1890 to 1910, they constructed sewers that were larger than what they had already built. They were 49 ft x 26 ft. And the city connected the Cholera Canal and the sewage system together.

People at that time dug hard and built up a well-functioning sewage system. Thanks to that, at last, the cholera outbreak ended.

I need to learn how to do that.

Having organized his thoughts, Lloyd spoke.

"Actually, the concept is simple. I'm going to make all the feces, urine, and other waste in the fiefdom flow through a different underground path, that is, completely separated from the existing river water and underground water."

"I suppose that will allow us to prevent the contamination of the river water and underground water. Is that right?" asked the count for confirmation.

"Yes. You are perfectly right. So, I have a favor to ask."

Lloyd had set the right mood for the construction of the great sewer, and the count understood the necessity of the construction. The timing to push ahead with the work was now. They couldn't hesitate. Similar to pulling out a splinter, they had to act in one clean stroke.

"I need a lot of manpower. As such, I was wondering if you could put out an official paper."

“What is the need for that?” asked the count.

“To recruit people,” explained Lloyd as he looked at the count filled with curiosity. “It will be a large-scale construction that covers the entire fiefdom. The manors, villages, refugee camps, and apartment complexes... Almost all residential areas will be dug to install sewers. But that is not the end of it.”

“What else is there?” asked the count.

“The wastewater needs to flow smoothly to the deserted land in the north. And, of course, we will have to dig the ground there as well,” added Lloyd.

“The construction will be huge.”

“Yes, my lord. Therefore, I need as many workers as possible.”

Lloyd was speaking the truth. He needed more than the existing engineering corp. What was more, they were already busy building up the apartment complex, which was a priority. The same went for the elf rebar workers and orc warriors.

“At the least, I can employ the White Cavalry,” explained Lloyd, “but the number is still severely lacking. So, I need the help of the people in the fiefdom and refugees.”

“Hmm, so that’s why you want to take volunteers,” said the count.

“Yes.”

Actually, Lloyd pondered for a second about mobilizing them by force. After all, the Frontera fiefdom had been promoted to a county, and it granted Lloyd and the count a host of powers. So, it wasn’t a challenge for Lloyd to mobilize the people in the fiefdom and refugees by force. But he didn’t feel like doing it because he still had a chip on his shoulder about his days in South Korea.

I worked my butt off but never received any payments on time... It was so awful.

He had broken his back in those days to make a living. But the world wielded violence against him. Overlooked. Ridiculed. However, that kind of treatment was actually nice compared to the real issue. What really gutted Lloyd the most was his delayed payments.

Money. I worked my fingers to the bone while my nose bled for that alone.

But his supervisors just apologized and said that there was nothing they could do. They told him all is well that ends well and promised that they would be paid in full after a few days. They were smiling and comforting him, so Lloyd had no choice but to reluctantly agree. But afterward…

I never saw them keep their promise and pay in full.

One late payment delayed the following ones as well. It was strange, but that was the case. And so, Lloyd became a bundle of nerves at times when he feared that he wouldn't be able to pay rent. He grew so self-conscious around the rental room manager that he couldn't eat properly.

Shoot. Thinking about it pisses me off to this day.

And he was still frustrated by what happened. The strong emotions he felt then remained with him.

Thus, I will never ever put people to work by force and for free.

Lloyd didn't wish to do the same trashy things to his people. So, he decided to never resort to such. That was his limit, even though he already was a cunning man. Plus, from the practical point of view, mandatory labor didn't look like a sound choice.

The people will grow discontent.

Of course, Lloyd could always silence their complaint. But it could break their trust, and it would be difficult to restore the broken trust.

I'll be just making people turn away from me. From then on, people won't volunteer for the projects I do. They'll think among themselves that joining

a construction project is a waste of time for them, that the work will harm their bodies without any reward in return...

If that happened, then Lloyd would be in a pickle. So, he quickly decided to never make a myopic choice, wherein he would exchange a long-term asset for a short-term benefit. With that determination in mind, Lloyd spoke.

“That is why we need the official document. To legally write a legal contract. But I’m guessing that there won’t be many volunteers,” said Lloyd.

“I believe so as well. After all, the harvest season is coming soon.”

The count nodded, and he was right. The spring was coming soon, and the entire fiefdom, including the refugees who recently received pieces of the reclaimed land, were getting ready for harvest.

“And yet, I have no choice. I must receive volunteers first and contract experts from Cremo city to make up for any lack of manpower afterward. That is, even if it costs money.”

“I see. Okay, I will write up an official document.”

“Thank you, my lord.”

The official document was written up in no time, and it spread fast and wide across the fiefdom. Lloyd didn’t get his hopes high about any volunteers because the conditions were very different from the time they constructed the terraced fields.

People went wild at that time because I promised them they would receive land if they joined the reclamation project. But it’s different this time. I can only offer them a regular wage this time. It will not appeal to them much when they’re already busy working their land. So, I should hire people from Cremo.

Thinking such, Lloyd flung himself on the bed.

“Whew.”

Drowsiness rushed through him. Lloyd wondered if it was because he had pulled an all-nighter the night before or moved around busily all day.

I should get some sleep first.

It was time to get some sound sleep. His worries could wait for the next day. Just like that, Lloyd drifted off to sleep with his shoes on. And soon…

Ding Dong.

[Your accomplishments and the compliments you have received until now are bringing about a comprehensive effect.]

[The majority of people in the fiefdom and the refugees who have read Count Frontera's official document "strongly" yearn to pay off their debts by helping you.]

A miraculous message, which Lloyd never ever expected, started to appear in front of his eyes.

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Chapter 142: Unexpected Linkage Effects (1)

“Bibeong!”

The morning arrived in Frontera county. At Bibeong’s wild and ferocious roar, which came from the eastern mountain range, people, livestock, birds, skylarks, frogs, and bees woke up from sleep. Lloyd was one of those that was awakened.

What the heck is this?

Lloyd pressed and rubbed his eyes once. It was a sweet, nice sleep, and he had slept with his shoes on in terrible fatigue.

Is it because I slept like a log? I’m seeing things.

Lloyd frowned, still groggy from sleepiness. He then started to read the messages he thought were a delusion.

[The residents and refugees in the fiefdom are voluntarily rolling up their sleeves to help you out.]

“…”

Lloyd didn’t believe a single thing mentioned in the message. To him, there was no such thing as voluntary work or volunteering. And what was more, the majority of the fiefdom’s people were offering their help, not just one or two. And so, Lloyd couldn’t believe what he just read.

Who would work for free? People work when there is free stuff like a box of tissue rolls, coupon book, or otherwise, a wage.

Humans were motivated by rewards. No one would work without it. No good deed was done without payment. The world wasn’t free. Every favor came with strings attached. That was what Lloyd believed in, which he naturally came to develop from the harsh and hectic life he had lived in South Korea. And that was equally the reason why he neither gave anything

for free nor tried to acquire something without payment. The same applied right now.

Roll up their sleeves? Like, I'd believe it.

All he did was simply plaster several official documents across Count Frontera. It promised appropriate monetary rewards for those who applied for the construction of the sewers. Although he announced the hiring notices, Lloyd didn't have high hopes for it.

The reward wasn't great.

And besides, it was spring, which was a busy season for farmers. Who would come to work for menial pay?

At most, I'd say a hundred. Still, even that's a generous estimation.

So, the rest were planned to be hired in Cremo. Lloyd shook his head as he confirmed the plan, driving away the dogged sleepiness that continued to harass him. But later, he noticed additional notifications below the messages that he couldn't believe were real.

[Your accomplishments and the compliments you received until now have compounded to bring about a linkage effect.]

"..."

What?

Lloyd's eyes started to move slowly. He selected a message, and it dropped open below for more detail.

Ding Dong.

[Long time ago, you punished the traitor of the fiefdom and created order. The people of Frontera county still remember the amazement and astonishment they felt toward you on that day.]

[The title “Exemplifying Punisher” draws basic trust in you from existing residents.]

[You have spearheaded the reconstruction of the crumbling fiefdom. Moreover, you took on a crucial role in clearing the family debt with your marvelous tenacity and planning. The residents of Frontera county are living witnesses of your endeavor and devotion.]

[Titles “Builder of the Dead Estates” and “The Eldest Son of Frontera” are greatly affecting people’s consciousness. No one in the fiefdom cast doubt on your construction plan.]

[You generously helped the refugees even when you did not have many resources. Tens of thousands of refugees deeply remember your grace and help.]

[Title “The Leader of the Weary” is drawing steadfast trust from the refugees toward you.]

[You have risked yourself and protected the people in the fiefdom by being their shield and fighting head-on despite the catastrophe ahead of you. Such feat numbers more than once. You charged underground to save the people during the wild ant invasion. You threw yourself into the dark magician’s dungeon to save the imprisoned soldiers. You volunteered as a bait to draw hundreds and thousands of locusts. The people in the fiefdom clearly remember your valor and sacrifice.]

[The title “Bell Saver” is spreading throughout the refugee camps through the mouths of the residents. The refugees, who already consider you their lifesaver, are overwhelmed with adoration by the marvelous tale.]

[A special effect has been created following the linkage effects.]

[All the people in the fiefdom and refugees came to revere you as one.]

[For a certain period, everyone in Frontera county will absolutely trust and support your plans and decisions.]

[Everyone, including the refugees, has determined to volunteer themselves for you without payment.]

[Compliment Linkage Effect Subject: Everyone in Frontera county.]

[Compliment Linkage Effect Period: Three Years.]

“Wow...”

Lloyd wondered if it was real. He gulped and read the message once again. Surely, what he was reading was true, so this was very real.

“My goodness.”

In fact, the great string of explanations that came afterward actually made it harder for him to believe they were real. He rose from his bed in a daze. Thinking that taking some fresh morning air would calm his excited heart, Lloyd drew the curtain and opened the bedroom window. But he froze in place once again.

“Waaaah!!!”

Clamoring cheers and roars blared as soon as he opened the window. Before Lloyd could take in a fresh morning breath, loud cheers harshly pierced his ears. The people were bustling outside. Beyond the courtyard and outside the main gate and at the manor entrance, there were at least a thousand people gathered despite it being early morning. They cheered and called for Lloyd, who appeared through the window.

Huh? Hold on a second.

Lloyd was flustered for a second. Reality hit him a second later.

It’s really true. That message just now was really true.

Lloyd got a grasp of the situation as he strove to regain composure. This was what seemed to have happened. His accomplishments and titles had accumulated together to bring about a compounded effect. As such, he became the most popular celebrity in the fiefdom, which enabled

innumerable people to come to the manor this morning to participate in the sewer construction.

Woah.

Lloyd wondered if he was going to be treated like a king at this rate. Then, he would have to say goodbye to living a relaxing life. Reluctant to the idea, Lloyd decided to act wisely. He then arranged his clothes and hair and went out of the bedroom. There, he bumped into the count and countess, who were both red.

“Did you see what’s going on outside the window? The crowd’s been causing a ruckus since earlier. They are volunteering and asking for work, and they say they will work without any payment. I never expected a few official documents to bring about such a reaction...”

“Well,” said Loyd, “you are a skilled writer, my lord. People must have been touched by your words.”

“I-Is that so?” asked the count.

“Yes, probably.”

Lloyd grinned and continued speaking to Count Frontera, who appeared uplifted by the sudden praise for his talent in writing.

“This is great news. We won’t have to trouble ourselves by hiring people from Cremo anymore. I am thinking of going in front of them now. May I?” said Lloyd.

“Go ahead. These people are here to work for you anyway.”

“Thank you, my lord.”

The count tapped Lloyd’s shoulder. Lloyd smiled at him, left the manor, and stood in front of the legion of residents and refugees gathered at the manor. Lloyd skipped the cheesy speech. Instead, he simply put up a table, which was for signing contracts.

“Okay. Line up, people! Line up!”

Lloyd needed to make hay when the sun shone. There was a time for everything, and just like how the large mast had to be spread against the smooth wind, and the laundry had to be left hanging under the bright sun, he thought the same should be done for the work contracts. He wanted to have people sit at the contract table when they were in their most zealous state and ready to work. Like right now. Lloyd stared across from the table and spoke in a thick-skinned manner.

“Okay, write your name and address. Then, your age, sex, height, and weight,” demanded Lloyd”

“Eh? My age? And why my sex and height-”

“Because every person has a different amount of strength and stamina. And getting rest and recovering differs according to age as well. Tell me, do you want me to put you to any work without considering those factors? Is that it?”

“Of course, it’s not that, but...”

“Right? Just imagine me pushing you to work when you’re dead tired, threatening to cut your wage, or giving you some menial task when it’s a rest day. That sounds horrible, doesn’t it?”

“Yes, yes...”

“So you will receive a daily wage. Nothing is free.”

“Excuse me?”

“Didn’t you hear me? You will be paid for your work.”

“But Master Lloyd, we don’t need any compensation-”

“Tsk,” said Lloyd, “I’m just doing it because I don’t want to be at the center of the gossip in the future. So, just take what you receive.”

“Oh, yes. I see.”

“Yes, good. The work schedule will be released once the construction begins, so focus on your harvest meanwhile, okay? How’s the Maritz land doing so far? And how are you?” Lloyd barraged him with questions.

“H-how did you know I live there?” said the man, a bit stupefied at Lloyd’s remark.

“Why wouldn’t I? You signed a contract with me.”

“Yes... I did.”

“And your kids?” asked Lloyd. “You told me you plan on sending your kids to Cremo for studies when you have saved up enough money.”

“How did you remember-”

“Do you wish for me to forget it?”

“Not at all,” said the man as he waved his hands. “Not at all. It’s just that I’m amazed how you remember me when I’m nothing...”

“Well, it’s nothing to be surprised about. Anyway, take care and go now. Make sure you get ready for the harvest and to read the official work schedule when it’s out.”

“Yes. Thank you, Master Lloyd.”

“Okay. Next.”

Just like that, conversations continued to take place. The applicants filled out the contract with Lloyd, who asked them to register their sex, age, height, and other things about them. Lloyd predicted a host of more applicants would sign up, many more than what he needed for the job. So, he decided to rotate them by shifts depending on their physical characteristics.

Rotating shifts. Yes. I mean, otherwise, who would work on farms and raise cows?

Even though the construction was a pressing matter, the harvest was equally significant. As such, Lloyd planned to operate in shifts to make sure that they won't get affected by farming.

And a daily wage. I have to give it to them at all costs.

Lloyd vowed to pay them daily wages. He didn't want to hire them for free even though they were volunteers. It wasn't because he had plenty of money left or suddenly possessed a philanthropic spirit. It was for his own sake and future.

Because hiring them for free will certainly lead to a scandal in the future.

Right now, people trusted and worked for him, but there was no guarantee that it would be so for eternity. Their cheer today could turn into criticism next.

I must reward them appropriately, so they'll have this mindset that I pay my workers. That's going to relieve them.

Once that mindset settled among the people, it would be easier for Lloyd to hire them in the future, and they would be more available at the most necessary times. In short, trust would be built. And just like that, Lloyd spent the whole day signing contracts with thousands of applicants. He was smiling throughout the time, and it went the same for the applicants. Happy grins. It was a heartwarming spectacle. But there was one who thought otherwise. Javier.

Whew. Truly, people don't know Master Lloyd's true self.

Javier was in charge of delivering the contract papers beside Lloyd. He sighed intermittently as he did, confused by how innocent these people could be. He couldn't wrap his head around what on earth it was about Master Lloyd that made them go berserk over him. Although he kept close to Lloyd's side, it was beyond Javier.

You get to know him, and you'll realize that he's a cunning and sly person.

Javier wanted to shout aloud that Lloyd was a con man. Everybody run! But of course, Javier, being an objective and cool-hearted man, succeeded in controlling his emotions and groaning inwardly. The contract signing ended in success, but Lloyd didn't stop there. He had more stuff to deal with.

Just one? No. I got piles and piles of work as high as a mountain.

Once the contract signing was finished, Lloyd spread his arms and stretched his fatigued body. Sure, the labor shortage was solved, but that didn't mean everything was A-OK.

The labor's been taken care of. Now, for the supplies.

Construction required more than people. Structures required supplies and creating grand sewers necessitated large stones.

"So, let's get dinner," said Lloyd.

"Excuse me?"

Javier titled his head as he was organizing the contract papers.

"I thought you wanted to have dinner. Where are you going?"

Javier asked because Lloyd was doing the opposite. The latter had gotten ready to go outside.

"Follow me, and you'll find out," Lloyd grinned as he shrugged on a coat.

"..."

Javier wondered what scheme his young master was resorting to this time. Plus, dinner wasn't happening until a few hours later. The knight left the manor, growing curious. He hopped on a horse and ran parallel to Lloyd. The sun was fading now, and Lloyd's horse darted to the south.

Is he going to the Lacona viscounty?

Javier wondered if Lloyd's plan involved getting dinner at the Lacona manor. But he soon realized that his young master wished to squeeze more than just a simple meal.

Master Lloyd would be more than capable of that.

Once you became an enemy of Master Lloyd, that remained unchanged for eternity. Lloyd would never stop pestering and harassing you until you are in your grave. That was the kind of person Lloyd was. Javier soon realized that he was right as the horses entered the Lacona territory. They ran past some villages and fields to arrive at the luxurious manor, which was owned by Viscount Lacona. But Javier noticed a small ruckus in the front yard.

A fight?

Two men were fist-fighting. Judging from the clothes, they appeared to be the servants working in the manor. But the problem was that one young man, who was decked out in fashionable clothes, was watching the fight seemingly in amusement.

"Jab properly, you bastards! Come on! The loser will sleep in the storage, okay?! And obviously won't get dinner. Got that?" yelled the young man.

A sizable physique. Sly eyes. Javier soon realized who it was.

It's the son of Viscount Lacona. Was it Diego?

Javier had last heard that he went to the royal academy just like Master Julian. He wondered when the latter came back when...

"Hey."

Lloyd strode across toward Diego's back. He placed his arm on Diego's shoulder, who was much preoccupied with the fight.

"Eh? Who are you?"

Diego wheeled around in surprise and locked his gaze with Lloyd. At that moment, Lloyd beamed, and his eyes held a grin so evil that even the devil

would’ve shaken its head at Lloyd’s depravity.

“Who else? It’s me. I’m asking this because I have some business here. What is your old man up to right now?”

But instead of giving an answer, Diego, the son of Viscount Lacona, hiccuped.

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Chapter 143: Unexpected Linkage Effects (2)

Diego Lacona, the son of Viscount Lacona. This young man once received considerable expectations from people around him. Even though he was not a genius, he was clever enough, and thanks to his large physique, Diego was strong. Sword fighting was one of his talents, and Sir Curno, the knight of the viscounty, praised him for his skills a few times. Just like this, he grew up surrounded by people who looked forward to his future. When he grew up, he studied in the royal academy, and things were going pretty well for him, that is until he encountered Lloyd Frontera, that fiend.

But... what's he doing here?

Diego hiccuped, and his neck bobbed. Chills ran down his spine against his will. His happiness index dropped to the bottom when he laid his eyes on this frightening figure. Diego snapped his eyes open.

"Eh?! Eh..."

Diego meant to say something, but his lips didn't move as he pleased. His esophagus was supposed to push the air to his throat. But he couldn't utter as though his lips were frozen. In other words, he jumped out of his skin.

"What are you so surprised about?" said Lloyd as he scoffed. He then tensed his arm that rested on Diego's shoulder, tugging the latter's head to his side.

"You must be glad to see me, right? That's why you didn't hear me properly. I just asked, 'what does your old geezer do?'"

"It's... It's..." muttered Diego.

"Come on. Speak slowly."

"The thing is..."

"Are you scared of me?"

“…”

Diego clamped his mouth shut. He didn’t want to admit it, but he was scared. Lloyd Frontera. The sight of this bastard should blow my gasket, Diego thought to himself. He was supposed to foam at his mouth in the presence of Lloyd. That was the only acceptable reaction when he recalled how wretchedly Lloyd had trampled him the last time, how he got expelled following Lloyd’s report on the rampant corruption in the academy, and how he was thrown behind bars for three months.

I was angry. So much so that I couldn’t control myself.

Diego grew up in the limelight, and he was praised for being a rightful member of the academy. But not anymore. As though the expulsion from the academy wasn’t bad enough, he was imprisoned under royal order. What this signified was clear: Permanent excommunication from the world of nobles. He would never hold an important position in the royal palace for life. And so, Diego was almost exiled to his hometown, and all his days were gripped with venomous bitterness.

Each time a wave of emotion rushed through him, he drank. And he pestered his servants and maids. Blowing off his steam in such a manner worked and appeased his heart. The same went for today. He had summoned two servants to force them to duel, so he could watch. At first, they hesitated, saying they could not do it and didn’t want to fight. Diego then brought a whip and snarled that he would whip anyone who disobeyed him. Just like that, Diego pushed everyone to a duel. Servants punched and struck each other. Their noses bled, and their eyes went black.

Amused, Diego giggled and egged them on all the more. He threatened that the loser would have to skip dinner. Not enough with that, the loser was supposed to spend the night in the storage. Diego pressed them until one of them was knocked out. But was it because the servants did something wrong? No. They were innocent. And yet, Diego didn’t feel guilty at all.

I’m allowed to do that. They are servants. They are mine. Why can’t I take my anger out on an object I own?

If Diego could blow off his steam by directing at his subjects, that was good enough. This was exactly what was happening when Lloyd came here. And right now...

I am not... angry.

It was as though he was splashed with a bucketful of cold water. Diego had been waiting for this moment to come. He vowed to rip Lloyd to pieces if their paths crossed again. But right now, even when his wish was granted and he saw Lloyd standing in front of him, Diego wasn't angry. Instead, instinctive fear started to smother him.

Bathump! Bathump! His heart pounded so loudly that he could hear it in his ears. The color drained from his face, and his hands turned cold and sweaty. And... he couldn't meet Lloyd in the eyes.

"Hello? Hey! Mister!" called Lloyd.

"..."

Lloyd's gaze. His gentle voice. His arm wrapped around Diego's shoulder. Each of these brought back his memories of the past, particularly the pain of Lloyd's blows and punches. Pain and fear were etched on Diego's bones. When his memories and senses returned to that moment, everything turned to fear instantly. And now, his shoulders shrugged and hunched over like a mouse that met its predator.

Tsk. He's just like his father.

Lloyd scoffed. Like father, like son. The two were living embodiments of the strong against the weak, weak against the strong. Moreover, they both owned a cunning inclination, in which they became groveling in the presence of someone stronger, and vice versa. Lloyd slightly pushed Diego's back, which stiffened with fear.

"If you can't speak, then guide me with your body. I'm here because I have business with your father," stated Lloyd.

“Uh, i-it’s...”

“Come on. Move now.”

“...”

Diego clumsily led the way, entered the manor, and walked along the corridor. But Lloyd didn’t utter a single word throughout the walk. At last, Diego stopped in front of the viscount’s office, and he pointed at the door, his fingers trembling. Then, he quickly turned around to leave.

“Hey.”

At last, Lloyd opened his mouth. Diego, who made to leave the area, flinched his shoulder as though he was struck with an arrow. The corners of Lloyd’s lips curled up.

“Come to think of it, you were harassing your servants, weren’t you?”

“...”

“How does it feel to pick on a weak and defenseless person?”

“...”

“Answer me,” ordered Lloyd.

“It’s... It’s...” muttered Diego.

“Tsk,” said Lloyd, “Forget it. Largely speaking, you do know that the servants of this manor are the people of my county, right?”

“...”

“They may be residents of your viscounty, but at the same time, they are the residents of my county,” reminded Lloyd. “And go larger, and they are the queen’s people. But look at you. I didn’t know until today that you’ve been mistreating the people of the county and of the queen like that. You just live

recklessly, don’t you? Hm? You’re completely ignorant and thoughtless, aren’t you?”

“Um, that’s... Well...” Diego found himself muttering.

“Are you trying to teach me how to murmur? I’m not interested. Learn it yourself.”

“...”

“I catch you treating them like that once again, and seriously, you can consider yourself dead,” threatened Lloyd.

“...”

“If you get me, then piss off.”

Lloyd didn’t want to talk diplomatically to this jerk. To Lloyd, Diego was like a beast controlled by his instincts, not by reason. It was as though his whole system was programmed to bite anything weaker than him. That kind of bastard didn’t deserve nice words.

“Tsk.”

Lloyd clucked his tongue as he looked at the back of Diego, who was scampering away. He then turned and happily knocked on the office door.

Knock knock.

“Who is it?”

Lloyd heard the viscount asking from the inside.

“Is dinner ready already?” The voice continued, “I thought I made myself clear that I don’t want to be bothered during my break unless the table is set.”

The viscount’s voice was now sterner. Lloyd, who was still standing outside the door, grinned happily.

“My, I am sorry, my lord. I didn’t know that, and-”

“You didn’t know? You didn’t know, and that’s it? What are you going to do when my sleep has already been disturbed, huh?” snarled Viscount Lacona.

“I swear,” said Lloyd, “I really was unaware. I truly was not aware it would bother you this much.”

“Are you kidding me right now?”

By now, Viscount Lacona’s voice had grown into yelling. But it only deepened Lloyd’s grin.

“My, my lord, please save me. I didn’t know. I truly mean it,” begged Lloyd.

“Ha, how persistent with you and your claim of ignorance! Who are you? You’re surely a servant, and you dare talk back to me? How dare you when you should have already opened the door and bowed your head down?”

“I am sorry. I profusely apologize.”

“My goodness! You are still apologizing?”

“But, my lord, you must understand my predicament. For you see, I have no way of knowing when you take your precious breaks as I do not frequent this manor very often,” explained Lloyd in a submissive voice”

“What? How dare you try to play games with me?”

“Of course not, my lord. What I am saying is true. Actually, I knocked on your door for a crucial matter.”

“A crucial matter?”

“Yes, my lord.”

“What could a servant possibly bring me a matter of significance that would disturb my break?!”

Slam! Clash! Lloyd wondered if the viscount hurled something toward the door. There was a ruckus inside following the viscount's shout. Then something shattered after hitting the door. This only made Lloyd happier. His grin deepened in amusement.

"I mean it, Viscount Lacona. I swear on it. I came due to a matter of grave importance," said Lloyd.

"If that is the case, you should open your door, bow, and report to me. Should I open the door for you when you're nothing but a lowly servant?!"

"Yes. You should open it for me."

"What is that...?" huffed the viscount.

"No, you will be made to jump to your feet and open the door for me. As the matter is that vital and important."

"What kind of gibberish and bullcrap are you saying now?" asked Viscount Lacona.

"It's neither gibberish nor bullcrap, my dear viscount."

"Ha... Hahaha. Hahaha? How dare you!"

The viscount's voice was now more violent. Lloyd could easily feel that the viscount's blood pressure was surging inside. He didn't need to see it.

"Fine. Fine. I will open the door for you, and listen to what you have to say. But I will punish you heavily if I regard your report as inconsequential."

"Yes, please do so."

"You won't stop will you…!"

"Please open the door, my lord," urged Lloyd.

"Fine! Tonight, I shall tie, whip, and skin you alive to let the people of this manor know what happens to those who make fun of their lord," warned

Viscount Lacona.

Rustle! Thud! Boink! There was a rustling noise of the clothes. Lloyd then heard the viscount stomping toward the door. The doorknob jerked heavily, and the door finally flew open.

Clack!

Lloyd put on a nonchalant smile on his face.

“It’s nice to meet you, viscount.”

“...”

“Truly, the matter is of grave importance,” said Lloyd, “in accordance with the strict will of Her Majesty for reconstruction, I plan on pushing ahead and constructing a quarry in the southern land of your viscounty.”

Viscount Lacona simply stood looking at Lloyd, dazed and speechless.

“Eh?! Do you not think it is important? You are not going to tie, whip, and skin me alive now, are you?” joked Lloyd.

“...”

“My, it’ll be a big problem if you do that.”

Thump! Viscount Lacona, who seemed to be stunned to see Lloyd, dropped to the floor with foam in his mouth.

***

The negotiation was easily settled. Viscount Lacona regained consciousness after about ten minutes, and he continuously bowed toward Lloyd as soon as he woke up. He begged, saying that he had been having hearing problems these days and didn’t recognize Lloyd’s voice. A grave mistake has been committed. Please understand with grand generosity. Please don’t tell Count Frontera about it. Viscount Lacona grabbed Lloyd’s both hands with so much earnestness and plea, and so the negotiation was easy.

“Good. I will turn a blind eye to your impertinent behavior and how you verbally abused me. That is, provided that you do what I ask,” said Lloyd.

Lloyd then proceeded to share his demands. From now on, Lloyd would build a quarry in the southern part of Lacona viscounty. Plus, Frontera county would hold the right to construct and manage the quarry and its products.

“Oh,” said Lloyd after a pause, “I’m just saying this, so we’re on the same page. This isn’t robbery, okay? And it’s obviously not extortion. I am sure you are aware of how Her Majesty has designated the Frontera county as the hub of reconstruction in the east, right?”

“Yes...”

“So since you are so refined and reasonable, viscount, I am sure you understand that the reconstruction effort will require a lot of resources,” said Lloyd.

“Yes...”

“Good. That’s the whole point. What you’re doing is providing that resource to us. I mean, the stones that will be quarried.”

Viscount Lacona didn’t speak.

“Just think about it,” explained Lloyd, “The rocks that are quarried from the site will be used in various constructions. They will become the basis of countless structures across the Frontera fiefdom, as well as the pillars and walls and roofs. How nice is that?”

“...”

Nice to you, said Viscount Lacona inwardly as he despaired. But Lloyd didn’t care what the former thought about his plan. So, he simply went on to speak in a joking manner.

“So, this is a great thing for you, actually. The Frontera fiefdom is at the center of reconstructing the region under the orders of Her Majesty, and

imagine if you supplied us with your stones, one of the key materials for the project. How glorious would that be?”

“Yes, yes, yes. I am honored...”

“Isn’t it?” smiled Lloyd. “So, if you want to shush me now, please sign here.”

“Ehem...”

At last, Viscount Lacona left a tear-soaked signature on the contract, and once again, the status difference between Viscount Lacona and Lloyd was highlighted. Just like that, Lloyd’s grand picture of the sewer construction started to flesh out.

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Chapter 144: A Half-Meant Joke (1)

Quarry. The place to dig up rocks. The facility promised a great amount of quality stones for constructing various structures, sculptures, and anything else. It was also the facility Lloyd needed most at the moment.

Duh. I absolutely need loads and loads of stones to properly make a large-scale sewer.

The sewer was to cover all areas of Frontera county, including the villages, the Maritz land, the terraced fields, and the apartment complex. So, it went without saying that it necessitated a lot of piles.

Sure, I could use metal and cement since I have Bangul. But realistically speaking, it's almost impossible.

Most of the metal bars and cement Bangul produced at the moment were being used in building the apartment complex. As such, it would fall short, that is, even if Lloyd worked hard to encourage Bangul.

After all, my summon partners aren't machines.

They were animals with clear limits. Lloyd could never abuse them to work over their limit.

I can't do that. Her bottom is going to get sore.

She had been blasting metal bars and bursting cement every day without fail. Her buttock didn't enjoy a moment of rest, so Lloyd was especially feeding her high-quality dirt to prevent any injury.

As such, Bangul can't be mobilized for this construction. I can't give her more than what she's doing right now. It's wiser to use stones instead of cement to build the sewers. Besides, that's going to be more advantageous in the long run.

Cement was a versatile material. Yes, indeed it was. But it wasn’t the go-to material for all types of construction. It cracked and broke down over time, and such faults necessitated meticulous inspection and repair. The cracked areas needed filling. That was the only way for a cement structure to last long.

Otherwise, the facility gets quickly worn down and crumbles. It’s a common occurrence in rural parts of Korea. There are many abandoned buildings that aren’t renovated anymore.

Lloyd didn’t wish the sewers to meet the same fate as those buildings because constructing them required a lot of effort and time. As such, he wanted them to be kept strong and solid for as long as possible.

And that’s why it’s more advantageous to use stones in this construction project.

Managing the sewers was expected to be difficult because of the humidity, which would wear them down faster. Not enough with that, its massive size, lack of light, and terrible stench would give a hellish time to Lloyd in terms of maintenance. Thus, the structure needed to be low maintenance, so it could stand on its own even without much inspection and repair.

And that is possible if we use stone. Particularly the granite.

Granite. Its inside was extremely homogeneous, which meant that there were no layers inside. Since there were no layers inside, it wasn’t prone to tilting, cracking, or splitting.

That is, it doesn’t change even after a long time. That’s why granite is widely used in the modern world as a supporting stone for semiconductors or measuring devices that require precision. It’s also the stone used in curling competitions.

It could easily bear massive weights and prevent the water from seeping. It was completely protected from external contamination. That was why it was used to build lighthouses exposed to harsh sea conditions. Using it allowed the structure to remain unchanged even after a long period of

leaving there without maintenance. Its robust and inflexible characteristics and permanent longevity were the reasons why Lloyd considered it the most suitable material for the upcoming construction.

“We’re going to make a quarry from here to there,” Lloyd instructed. “So, what you need to do is dig up all the dirt in this slope. Okay, let’s get started. Give me a shout before we start. Let’s go!”

Lloyd was at the foot of the mountain in the south of Lacona viscounty. He pointed at the area with his finger, and the engineering corp, the White Cavalry, and the orc warriors grabbed their shovels. Giant Ppodong gazed at it with a glimmer in his eyes. Bibeong stretched his towering front legs. The two of them were joined by five baby Mastodons Sir Bayern raised.

“Chuuu!!”

Even though these baby Mastodons were just seven or eight months old, they were double the size of ordinary bulls. Sir Bayern stroked them gently as they dragged across the land using giant plows.

Things are going great. As I thought, large-scale constructions are impossible without machines and equipment.

Lloyd’s eyes shone with satisfaction as they looked around the construction site, which he had looked into with his Subterranean Scanning skill. He learned that about 10 feet under the slope, there lay granite bedrock. He was already decisive about this place before visiting Viscount Lacona, almost forcing him to agree to the construction. Since Lloyd decided to push ahead with this project without any reservation and hesitation, he had brought all his summon partners and workers to help him.

“Clear the area, the trees, and everything else! Until the bedrock is revealed!”

“Wooo!!!”

“Oink!”

“Ppodong!”

“Bibeong!”

“Chu!!”

Lloyd grabbed a shovel and led the way, showing what shoveling was to the others as he used the Asrahan Core Technique. The engineers, who thought they were now seasoned shovelers, sent adoring and revering gazes at Lloyd. The White Cavalry became busier after suddenly being competitive. And the orc warriors happily shoveled as their pecs burst from their daily exercise. The construction picked up its speed, and after six days of ongoing shoveling, the mountain slope was perfectly transformed into a quarry. The thick bushes of trees were nowhere to be found, and the moist dirt was moved elsewhere. There was only a bedrock of granite left behind.

Now it’s time to build the transportation route to move the stones from the quarry.

There was more to the job than digging up rocks. They needed to be safely moved. To conveniently do that, a paved path was necessary as rocks were naturally big and heavy.

“Sir Bayern. You do know how to pave roads, right? You’ve done it before.”

“Yes, of course,” answered Sir Bayern.

“The process is the same. The width, depth, materials, and the order. Do you remember everything?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, I do,” Sir Bayern answered confidently.

“But I will attach the detailed design just in case. And Ppodong will be with you as he worked with you in the previous construction. As for the engineers... Will 150 be enough for you?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, that will be enough.”

“All right. So the route will start from the quarry, pass the Maritz Land, and go north until this point. You simply have to follow the construction plan and blueprint. Oh, and one more thing. All the roads must be kept as straight as possible. Make sure to remember this part.”

“I’ll make sure to remember your words.”

“Good. I’ll put my trust in you.”

“You can count on me, young master,” assured Sir Bayern with confidence.

Lloyd entrusted the job of constructing the southern highway to Sir Bayern, who held a plethora of experience supervising various projects in his three years of commanding the engineering corp. He was a stoic man, and that made him trustworthy. Although Lloyd had one less job to do, he still had a lot of other work.

Okay, next, the apartment complex.

It was spring already now, so the time had come to resume the construction of the apartment complex, which was paused due to the frigid temperature. Since everyone needed to move into the building before winter, Lloyd didn’t have any time to waste.

The good thing is that I have people who can lead the apartment construction while I focus on the sewers.

Lloyd grinned and turned to the elf archers.

“Right, Moira?” asked Lloyd.

“I don’t know what you are referring to, but I am glad that we have something to work on again,” Moira, the chief of the elf tribe, smiled faintly at Lloyd’s question.

She glanced at Building 103, whose foundation was currently being built.

“To be honest, I was bored all throughout winter. I wished for spring to arrive soon.”

“Why is that?” asked Lloyd.

“I wanted to jump around the high-rise apartment,” Moira said as her eyes darted to Building 102, which stood tall in its stately height. “I still cannot forget the early winter of last year. The time when I zoomed around the eighth floor of Building 102. I’ve never felt that way before.”

Moira’s voice sounded slightly faint. She couldn’t forget the feeling of slipping and slithering through the metal bars that shot upward on the tall building. It was rejuvenating to cut across the wind as she stepped on the outer wall and safety net. The sensation was akin to pleasure.

“The other elves have been waiting for spring to come too. We cannot wait to construct Building 103 to be taller.”

That way, they could fly around using the outer walls as footsteps. If there were dozens of apartment buildings in the area, they would then be able to jump around like squirrels from one roof to another. The mere thought of it charged Moira with excitement.

“Sounds great,” said Lloyd happily. “But you can’t do a perfunctory job just because you want it to finish fast. Then again, you are as meticulous as I am, so I have nothing to worry about.”

“Surely,” Moira agreed, you don’t have to worry, and besides, we all memorized the design blueprint you handed to us.”

That was how meticulous and thorough the elves were. And they had gained experience doing construction work last winter when they built the eighth floor of Building 102. Therefore, Lloyd decided that it was a safe bet to leave the construction to them, the natural metal rebar workers. Assembling the metal rebars and formworks could be assigned to them, and everything would be good as long as he put experienced and seasoned engineers at their side. And as for Lloyd himself...

I simply have to supervise them as I go around.

But he didn’t intend to rest. Even if he wanted to, rest was a luxury for him as there was a task only he was capable of. It was the survey of the construction of the sewer.

Woah. I can’t believe I don’t have any time to rest. Is this even real?

The next day, Lloyd went around the entire fiefdom, using the Asrahan Core Technique the entire time. After he recharged enough mana, he then used every bit of it to survey without a break. He scanned so much as the tiniest corners of the terrain in the fiefdom as far as his skill allowed. Then, he came up with the sewer model in the process.

It should be significantly larger than the pipes made out of concrete. It should be shaped like a large underground tunnel that’s big enough for people to enter.

That allowed for easy maintenance as people could directly enter the tunnels if there was a problem with the sewer.

So, I should go big. Just like the sewers in European cities.

The tunnel was to be composed of a central path where the waste and sewage would flow, and it would be flanked by pathways through which people could walk on foot. Lloyd decided to go with that juxtaposition.

And the lower part of the cross-section should be a reverse egg shape. That’s going to speed up the sewage and minimize junk piling up at the bottom.

Lloyd’s plan was fleshed out in his head, but that didn’t put an end to his deliberation. It only grew as the sewer plan started to take more shape. There was one problem that he couldn’t figure out, no matter how much surveying and designing he did.

Hmm. It’s just like I had expected. The sludge removal is the issue.

Sludge was a residue that accumulated in the process of treating sewage. When sewage was left in one place, liquid and semi-solid materials would

separate from one another. The former naturally floated to the top, while the latter sank because of its weight. When the sunken residue piled up, it became sludge. At that point, Lloyd had to gather them together, divide them using microorganisms, and squeeze the liquid out of them.

Then, they have to be buried, thrown in the sea, or burned. That's how we take care of sludge in the modern world.

But right now, it was a bit of a conundrum in this world.

Sure, I can gather sludge since building a sludge thickener at the end of the sewers is easy. That would make the sewage flow and gather at only one point, and the sludge would sink eventually. But the question is, how do I treat the sludge after it's gathered?

Employ the engineers? Bury the sludge? Lloyd shook his head.

No, that's impossible.

First of all, there would be a massive amount of sludge and not to mention the poisonous gas emitted from it. The sludge was a highly concentrated, rotten form of human waste from countless people, so it produced an unimaginable volume of methane that would be enough to suffocate the engineers to death.

That would be the same for the orcs and elves alike, not just the engineers.

The fantastical creatures weren't suitable for the job as well. Moreover, even if Lloyd managed to dig up the sludge safely, there was another problem: There was no suitable place to bury it.

I don't have the land for that in my fiefdom. Take them and throw them away? That was going to be another pickle as the land wasn't Lloyd's. Even if it was, moving the sludge alone would be too expensive. *Hmm... What should I do?*

Lloyd grimaced, his brows furrowing.

The best method is to incinerate them with searing heat.

Just one plume of fire would decimate the gas, microorganisms, and whatnot. How convenient would it be if I could do it? Lloyd asked himself. From then on, he locked himself in his bedroom and deliberated for three days. When he finally left the bedroom, he called Javier and spoke.

“We should go for a picnic,” Lloyd suggested.

“Excuse me...?”

Javier’s brows rose upward. He then spoke, and his voice was filled with curiosity.

“Picnic out of the blue? Where and why?” blurted Javier.

“To a dragon lair. To meet a dragon.”

“...”

There was so much nonchalance in Lloyd’s answer. It was as though he was suggesting that they go grab lunch at the cafeteria or coffee at a cafe. As such, Javier regarded it as nothing but a silly joke, at least for now.

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Chapter 145: A Half-Meant Joke (2)

There were untold numbers of caves throughout the world, and most had owners. For example, a tiger’s den was occupied by tigers, and you could find snakes coiling up in their cave. A cozy cave was for the brown bears to hibernate in the winter. And the fiery lair, located at the end of the southern end of the eastern range, wasn’t an exception.

“I hate being single... I want to fall in love.”

A resentful sigh rang aloud the deeper part of the fiery dungeon. Later, a large figure tossed and turned.

Thud! Thump!

Because of his 557-foot physique, a simple turn gave an impression of a hill moving. His 6,000-ton weight caused the entire dungeon to boom when his waist only touched the ground as he turned.

“I am so... lonely now,” Solitas, a red dragon owning the fiery den, murmured. But no answer came except for a meaningless echo of his words that traveled as his voice hit the walls of the vast place. The truth dampened Solitas’s heart all the more.

Dammit. It wouldn’t echo this much had I stacked up more treasures in here.

His red eyes scanned the center of the dungeon with annoyance. The place was empty and plain. There weren’t any crowns or treasure chests that were commonly found in dragon dungeons. There weren’t any rare jewels, let alone the comparatively mundane piles of gold. Solitas was, in fact, a penniless dragon.

Tsk. This is why I’m single.

Solitas’s gaze now reflected greater annoyance and grief. Once again, he sighed.

I wish I wasn't a dragon.

Solitas wondered what it would have been like if he were a human. Then, he would be free from the pressure of this money-grubbing destiny just to get married.

Probably. Humans look like they only need to farm to get married and have children and live happily until they die.

If this dragon's thoughts were spoken aloud in the presence of job seekers, newlyweds, younger generations, and others living in the twenty-first century, they would have cocked their heads, wondering if they heard him right. But being the ignorant dragon Solitas was, he drew a sigh and grumbled.

Ahh. I want to get married! I want to meet my wife!

But the problem was that Solitas didn't have any money. He lacked gold and silver. So even if he got married, he wouldn't have any food, that is gold and jewels, to feed his hatchlings. Gold and jewels were food for hatchlings, but Solitas didn't have any. As such, no dragon attempted to get married to him, and that was his biggest problem.

If times were different, I'd have ambushed human cities and threatened them.

Another sigh. Solitas had heard the story from his mother when he was still a hatchling. A long time ago, that is about hundreds of years ago, dragons had it easy. Accumulating treasures wasn't a difficult task. There were lots of convenient methods.

We simply had to attack cities and threaten the kings, kidnap hundreds of dwarf masters and put them into forced labor, or steal the treasure storage of greedy and scheming nobles.

Dragons of the past could easily accumulate wealth in that simple manner, and they got married quite easily. But now, such a method was no longer available. It was hundreds of years ago Dragon King Verkis cooperated with

dragons of the older generations to declare to the world “The Dragon Commandment.”

To hell with the Dragon Commandment!

The commandment brought about a myriad of changes to their lifestyle. It banned them from pilfering human cities, and threatening was no longer an acceptable method. Kidnapping dwarves into slavery was equally forbidden. In other words, the commandment declared peace across all races and restricted all dragons from any activities that posed a threat to other races without a clear basis. That was what the commandment was about.

Up yours! It’s so disgusting how they act nice and gentle when they've spent their entire lives putting humans to hard labor and threatening to usurp mountains of their gold and treasures! What a bunch of hypocrites!

Sure, the dragon king Verkis had married a human girl and eliminated an evil dragon that once wiped out the world. And Verkis did devise the commandment with excellent intentions as he brought about peace and prosperity among the races. But Solitas was just a fledgling at 1,050 years old. To him, the commandment was beyond his reason, and he felt particularly so toward the “New Guidelines on Accumulating Wealth,” which was a recommendation in the Dragon Commandment.

No pilfering or threatening other races. And what, veins of treasure ought to be discovered on my own! And since dragons have massive strength and stamina, we are to directly dig up giant minerals that can be found in the mantle, which humans and dwarfs can’t reach. And we should process the minerals with our abilities and magic to produce treasures... Crap.

That was the problem. Solitas had complied with the guideline at first, so the first thing he did after becoming independent was searching for a vein of treasure. He rushed dozens of miles deep into the underground and finally came across a vein of diamond. He dug up large piles of unprocessed diamonds with superior strength and stamina. But he encountered a problem next.

I couldn’t process them.

Solitas put in quite a lot of effort, but his painstaking attempts didn’t translate to good results. Even though he further concentrated his attention and worked harder, the shapes of the diamond came out all rugged and unbalanced. Cracks and chips to the stones were frequent. Not even a single one came out successfully, even though Solitas processed a hundred of them. The reason behind his failure was simple.

Damn these clumsy hands!

Solitas berated his rough and unskilled craftsmanship. No matter how much he toiled away, the result was the same. He wondered if he was cursed with clumsy hands. So even though Solitas spent all his time digging up minerals, his efforts were useless as he couldn’t process the minerals properly. Since poorly processed gems and stones were worthless, he didn’t have a thing to store in his dungeon.

I’m a failure. After all, I failed to get treasures even after I became independent.

The thought caused Solitas to let out another sigh.

I should be accumulating treasures right now. That’s how I can feed my hatchling that will be born when I get married. But I got nothing in my hands. It means my babies will die of hunger even if they come into the world. What kind of foolish dragon out there would want to marry and have babies with me?

Solitas put himself in the shoes of the female dragons, and he instantly knew that he was hopeless. He had no chance in the marriage market, and that was where he was at.

Whew... I don’t know. Should I just give up on marriage?

It had been 50 years since he became a fully-grown dragon. And he was starting to have such thoughts these days. Solitas was scratching the floor of the dungeon in resignation when...

“Hmm...?”

Solitas, who was about to sigh again, stopped and lifted his giant head to gaze at the pathway that led to the outside. He felt something near there.

“Invaders?”

They weren’t near. Actually, the invaders were near the dungeon entrance, which was situated very far from where Solitas was. It was that the magical trap installed there had been activated. But Solitaas soon sensed that the trap got destroyed and dismantled. In other words, there was someone entering the dungeon after breaking the traps. Solitas activated his transcendental senses unique to dragons, and he identified who these invaders were in a flash.

Humans. Two of them. How dare they?!

Boom! Solitas lifted his giant body, his four pillar-like legs rising up later. His wings, whose one side stretched about 200 yards, spread far and wide. His red eyes held a glint of deathly anger.

Good. I was just getting stressed. I shall tear you two into tiny pieces. Grrrr...

Enraged, Solitas walked toward the direction where the invaders were.

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Kaboom! An acidic solution was discharged from the stone to flood throughout the tunnel. But the attack didn’t last long.

Swish! Swoosh! A long sword glinted in the air vertically like a streak of lightning. It cut the space in one stroke, slashing the acidic solution that had filled up the space. Then, it was followed by a storm of wind created by the sword.

Kaboom! The overwhelming blow of the sword dried the acidic solution without leaving behind a single drop. And once a vacuum was created for a split second, Javier sprinted ahead.

Jump! Three light jumps. Those were all Javier needed to cover about 100 feet. Then, he wielded his sword as soon as he landed.

Clatter! Boom! A slab of stone marked with a delicate magic circle was sliced in half. The flow of the acidic solution then stopped.

“Whew.”

Javier breathed in. For a split second, Lloyd and Javier fell into danger as he had never expected that a terrible acidic solution would spurt from the stone. Javier turned and looked at Lloyd behind him.

“Are you okay, Young Master?”

“Yeah, roughly.”

Javier heard the nonchalant answer traveling from the outer part of the passage. Later, Lloyd shrugged and appeared in sight. Javier secretly let out a sigh.

What in the world am I doing here? Invading a dragon’s dungeon? Seriously?

It never occurred to Javier that Master Lloyd was being serious about it. Really. About ten days ago, Lloyd had suggested Javier go on a picnic. Javier was confused, so he asked with a grimace on his face why and where this picnic was taking place. Then Lloyd answered...

“To a dragon lair. To meet a dragon.”

At that time, Javier thought it was a joke. He thought so even when Lloyd held out a bag full of food and camping equipment and when they hopped on their horses. Javier simply thought that he was up to something again, but it would only require him to protect Lloyd, and that was it. Nothing more. This mindset lasted throughout their ten-day travel. Sometimes, Javier did ask Lloyd where they were heading, and Lloyd would shrug and say, “I told you. To a dragon lair.” Javier still thought that Master Lloyd was joking in an attempt to mask the real destination for some mysterious

reasons. Javier thought that was the reason why Lloyd was throwing such a nasty and corny joke. So, Javier was absolutely shocked that they would be visiting the dragon lair right now!

“Whew...”

Javier never thought that the young master he served was this much of a nutjob. Javier suddenly felt a pang of resignation toward the human race as a whole.

“So I wish to ask once again. Do you have any thoughts on turning back here?” Javier asked sincerely, but Lloyd simply raised his brows.

“No, I don’t.”

“...”

“What? Why? What?”

Javier glared at him.

“I came here because I have a plan. So you simply have to trust me and break through the traps just like you did right now,” explained Lloyd.

“Whew... Sure, I can break through the trap whenever I want, but...”

Javier spoke as he sighed.

“How long do I have to break through these traps? I want to know if I have to charge forward until I encounter the dragon,” asked Javier.

“Yeah, you are correct.”

“...”

“You are to move forward until we meet the dragon,” Lloyd stated.

“...”

“I’ve been telling you all these times,” huffed Lloyd. “We’re heading to a dragon lair. And we’re going to meet a dragon.”

“But-”

“It’s all right,” Lloyd interrupted, “I have a plan.”

“...”

Javier was suspicious of whether Lloyd had a plan. He was dumbfounded, but there wasn’t anything he could do. He had already set foot in the cave.

Should I just trust him again?

Javier gathered himself and remembered that Master Lloyd could be trusted when he acted like this. Lloyd frequently came up with plans that Javier had never even dreamed of in the past. So, he needed to put his faith in Master Lloyd.

And in case Master Lloyd’s measure doesn’t work, I’m going to run to the best of my ability.

Javier was determined such as he walked. He would protect his young master first should an unexpected danger appear.

Creak. Clank! Boom!

A host of traps tried to stop Javier in numerous ways. On top of the acidic solution, a streak of lightning, fire, poison-smeared arrow, and mist explosion attempted to kill him. Falling rocks and nightmarish ghosts. Frigid air and blinding flashlight. Each trap seemed to test Javier’s human limit. But Javier was a sword master and had already surpassed that limit. All he needed to do was wield his sword to slice, break, distort, and split the traps. No amount of clever trickery could deceive his senses, and the traps weren’t enough to hurt him. After moving forward and passing through dozens of passages and corners, a plain lot finally appeared in front of them. A giant creature with red skin was looking down at them.

“So you two are the ones who invaded my dungeon.”

Fwoosh! The red dragon threw the question at them, and it was a simple question. But that alone created a stormy echo across the whole space. But it wasn’t just a simple echo.

“...!”

Javier’s whole body trembled, and the pressure was so powerful that every single cell in his body seemed to scream aloud. So he hurried to stand in front of Lloyd when he felt the shockwave. Raising the sword high, Javier created an aura.

Bzzt!

The brilliant sword light wrapped the sword, and Javier reverberated the aura to engulf the whole space.

Bzzt!

The shockwave flowing from the aura shook the air and trembled at the same speed as the shockwave resonated and canceled one another.

Kaboom!

The two wavelengths crashed right in front of him and dissipated. Right after Javier defended the dragon’s first blow, he wheeled around and spoke.

“Master Lloyd, tell me the plan you have right now.”

It was time to respond. Javier’s voice grew hasty. The collision a moment ago convinced Javier that the dragon wasn’t a fabrication. It was real, so any haphazard response only meant death. Javier was right about it because Solitas drew in another breath once more.

Breath.

Javier could sense it. This dragon was breathing in to let out its most formidable weapon and power—breath. Time was running out. Javier pressed Lloyd once again as he had to act at once.

“Master Lloyd.”

“Yeah? Oh, but you see, my plan is already happening,” Lloyd said.

“Excuse me...?”

Javier didn’t understand what this young master was saying. How was his plan taking place right now?

Just then, Lloyd spoke with a strange smile on his face. “You.”

“Excuse me?” Javier asked again.

“I said, you.”

“...”

No way.

“What are you doing? Go fight,” directed Lloyd.

“...”

Is he serious?

“You can easily beat this dragon,” assured Lloyd.

“...”

Javier gazed at Lloyd incredulously and wondered if his young master had irrevocably lost it. But at the same time, Javier thought it was very strange that Lloyd was so composed. It appeared as though the latter fully trusted Javier without a hint of doubt. Lloyd simply looked at Javier with a composed face and gaze and pointed at the dragon with his cheek. Just then, the red dragon opened its mouth and discharged terrible heat.

Fwoosh! Solitas launched his breath, and the storm of heat, which was like fire from hell, swept over them.

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Chapter 146: Single No More (1)

Dragon breath.

Fwoosh! Solitas, the red dragon, opened his giant mouth, and a searing heat gushed out of his throat like torrential waves, burning and destroying the whole area.

“...!”

Javier’s eyes widened in surprise. His instinct signaled danger and commanded him to avoid it at once. Instinct preceded reason, and sense preceded instinct. Javier was already moving before he sensed danger.

Swish!

Javier held out his right hand but didn’t draw his sword. Instead, he grabbed Lloyd’s right shoulder, ducked down, slipped his left hand between Lloyd’s legs, and stood up, carrying Lloyd on his shoulders. Lloyd was taken in the air like a bag of rice. The lifting method was similar to the patient transfer technique taught by South Korean armed forces.

“Eh?”

Javier heard Lloyd’s surprised breath, but he had no time to respond. He jumped to his feet instantly.

Thwack!

He flung his body high with Lloyd on his shoulder, and the dragon breath swept the very spot the two were standing on.

Boooom! The breath overwhelmed the whole place, and Javier felt his hair rising from the horrendous spectacle. At the same time, he noticed something odd.

It’s not hot...

Javier had meant to haul his sword and block the attack with his aura shield as the breath was passing right beside him. That was the only way to block this terrible heat. He was grabbing the hilt of the sword when...

Why isn't it hot?

Javier didn't feel the heat at all, even as the gust of breath brushed just several feet away from him. It simply felt warm and nothing more.

How?

It was truly odd. Sitting in front of a small bonfire would be hotter than this. His face used to get hotter when he grilled meat on a pan. But now wasn't the time to entertain his curiosity.

Tap! Jump!

Javier landed only to leap high once again, growing more distant from the series of breaths coming at him. Just then, he suddenly recalled an event that happened about two hours ago.

Is it because of the cream Master Lloyd had given me?

Right before he entered the fiery den of the dragon, Javier was left rooted to the spot as the intimidating den appeared in his eyes. Lloyd then held out a large bottle to him and spoke.

"Apply it on your body. Make sure to cover every corner of it unless you wish to burn to death."

Javier didn't notice what it was until he opened the cork. An aroma assaulted his nose. It was the Elensia sap Lloyd had acquired from the elves' forest.

"It's not mixed with bean oil. It's in its purest form."

Lloyd spoke as though he was doing a favor to Javier, and he instructed him to remove his clothes and smear every corner of his body with the lotion.

He made him slather his clothes and even his sword. Not a single spot was missed.

“Apply it generously. Don’t even try to be frugal. I know it’s precious, but it doesn’t cost more than your life. So go all out! Smear it so thick that it not only blocks the heat but any human interactions.”

So, Javier did what he was told to do. Not a single strand of hair was left uncoated with the oil. Even the cuticles of his nails received a layer of the lotion.

All that was... for this moment.

Now, it dawned on Javier that this Elensia Tree sap was much more effective than he had vaguely imagined. He could feel it in his bones.

I suppose that was why he was so confident.

Javier actually wondered what it was that made Lloyd swell with confidence when they were entering the dungeon and how he could maintain such composure in the face of the dragon.

“Did you already expect that applying the Elensia sap would protect me from the dragon’s breath?” asked Javier.

“Well, yeah, something like that,” replied Lloyd.

Javier put Lloyd down as soon he landed and hid between the rocks. Lloyd, who was treated like a cargo load a moment ago, scoffed, thinking how right Javier was when he asked if Lloyd believed the sap would work.

“I heard about it,” added Lloyd.

“What do you mean?”

“This method was used by the knight of blood and iron.”

“The knight... of blood and iron?” repeated Javier, dazed.

“Yeah.”

It was true. Javier used this same method in the novel. He smeared his body in the Elensia Tree sap and made armor by solidifying it. Then, he confronted that red dragon, Solitas. The result? He was A-OK even when he was engulfed by his breath. The fight lasted for three days straight. At last, Javier succeeded in snapping the horn of the dragon, making him run for his life when the defeat was near. So, in other words, the act of smearing the Elensia Tree sap was verified to neutralize the red dragon’s breath in the novel.

“But I have a question.”

Javier’s eyes glimmered as he looked at Lloyd.

“I think you mentioned him the other time as well,” said Javier, “Who on earth is this knight of blood and iron?”

“Oh, him? " asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

Who else? It’s you.

Lloyd put on a grin and nonchalantly replied, “Someone who’s way more handsome, stronger, and more popular than you.”

“Are you sure?” Javier’s eyebrow quirked.

“Wow. Look how quick you are to doubt me,” said Lloyd.

“Fine, even if there is such a knight, this is just outrageous,” defied Javier.

“How is it outrageous?”

“This, fighting against the dragon.”

Javier’s eyes grew more serious. The discharge of the dragon breath was thinning now, and he quickly glanced around before speaking.

“It is beyond me what you are after that you should fight the dragon, but he’s never to be taken lightly. Let me correct myself. You will have to risk your life, but that won’t be enough. Did you not consider this risk at all?” asked Javier.

“Well, I did,” drawled Lloyd.

“Then why did you-”

“I had you, so I thought it’d be fine.”

“What?” Javier furrowed his brows, sending a confused gaze at him. He then looked around, and his face suddenly looked urgent. Lloyd continued to speak as he looked at Javier.

“I know that you feel pressured because it’s your first time fighting the dragon, but don’t get scared.”

“What are you saying-”

“I mean, go out and fight,” said Lloyd.

“Eh?”

Tap. Lloyd slightly pushed Javier. He staggered from the unexpected attack and was thrown out in the open.

“Master Lloyd...?”

Javier stared at Lloyd, wide-eyed. Lloyd clenched his fists and cheered the latter.

“You can do it!”

“...!”

Javier cursed his young master under his breath even though he wanted to ream Lloyd out aloud. But he just didn’t have any time for it as he locked his eyes with Solitas.

Whoosh The dragon’s tail flew down like a giant whip just then. It was as though Solitas wasn’t interested in finding out why they barged in. The dragon simply wielded his tail like how humans swatted flies with their hands.

“Hmph!”

Javier drew his sword, but he didn’t think of taking the blow of the giant tail with this sword.

I must ensure Master Lloyd’s safety first.

Jump! He leaped high to tear himself far away from the crack of the rock where Lloyd was hiding. To Javier’s relief, the dragon's tail pursued him, crashing down on him like a mountain falling down from the sky.

Boooom! The ground shook, and the inside of the dungeon blared. Javier, who closely avoided the splattering rocks and overwhelming shockwave, started to sprint ahead.

The dragon’s much faster than I’d thought.

Javier became nervous. He could feel his back breaking out in a cold sweat. The tail blow came half a second earlier than Javier expected.

If I had been a little slower and tried to induce him to attack me, he’d have killed me.

Javier’s hair stood on end. One blow, and he was done for. It didn’t make any difference that he was a sword master. From then on...

Then I must speed up as well.

Zing! He activated his three mana circles and made his movement faster.

Tap! He jumped to his feet, throwing himself as he dashed like the wind. Going against gravity, he ran as he used the wall as his footing. Solitas started to attack him.

Rumble! He whacked him with his tail and struck down with his front paws. Then, he spread his wings to create a storm, flying high and using magic against Javier. Fiery and icy blasts of wind wreaked havoc in the place. But Javier managed to closely avoid all the attacks and succeeded in drawing the dragon far from Lloyd. As he watched the fight from a distance, Lloyd brimmed with confidence.

I knew it.

Javier was strong, and he was now more powerful than when he fought against the dragon in the novel. So, there was a zero chance that Javier would lose to that red dragon.

That's why I brought you here. And besides, that dragon should be a surprisingly easy opponent.

The red dragon Solitas was a powerful dragon. There was no debate about it. But at the same time, he was not that powerful.

Sure, he's naturally powerful because he's a dragon to the point that no living creatures could dare compete with him. But he's weak when compared with the other dragons. He's almost the weakest, actually. The reason is simple. He's young. Just a fledgling.

The Knight of Blood and Iron's plot suddenly came to Lloyd's mind. It must have been the episode where Javier went on an adventure in the woods of the elves. The last part of the episode tackled the confrontation between Javier and Solitas, and it mentioned something about Solitas.

He's young. About 1,050 years old. Just 50 years since he outgrew the hatchling phase. He's about as old as a high school student.

A dragon's power was directly proportional to its age. That is, the older they were, the stronger they became.

It's similar to a human's wealth. People normally advance in their careers and make more money over the years on the condition that they get a job and work consistently. So, comparing a dragon's combat power to a

human's wealth, he'd be on a similar level as a high school student's bank account at the moment.

That was the combat power of Solitas.

So, Javier, you can win. Don't cower. Trample him. Dampen his spirit and show that you're more powerful.

Javier's task for today was clear: highlight their difference in power and prove that he was on another level. That was the only way Lloyd could proceed to the next step of his plan.

Humans and dragons alike, it's the same. They all become meek and modest in the presence of the strong. That's why he must discourage him. So, that the red dragon will be ready to hear my offer. From there, I can start the negotiation.

Lloyd needed help from the red dragon to efficiently take care of the sludge that would come out from the sewer he would build next. And so, the dragon's help couldn't come without negotiation and persuasion.

Javier, don't just avoid his attacks! Whack him!

Lloyd stared at Javier, internally waving his cheer sticks at him. Javier was crisscrossing the area, closely avoiding Solitas's attacks that came incessantly. Suddenly, there appeared a light of determination in his eyes.

Dragging things will only put me at a disadvantage. It's going to put Master Lloyd at risk. I must barrage the dragon with attacks. I should do a hit-and-run. Knock him out and retreat.

Running away like this wasn't going to achieve anything. But it was equally foolish to fight the dragon head-on. It was more foolish to drag things to no end. Therefore, he ought to go all out in one stroke to stop the dragon from attacking. The moment the dragon flinched, he would take Lloyd and run to somewhere safe.

I can do it.

Evasion instead of direct confrontation. Javier's eyes flashed with determination after he decided on his tactic. His execution had to come without hesitation, and his offense had to be unreserved.

Grip! The moment Javier tightened his grip, the counterattack began.

Ziiing! Three mana circles rotated, sucking the mana around him. After he amplified it, he transferred it to his manaheart.

Crash! Boom!

His manaheart thumped with his heart, racing fast in rapid beats as the latter took in the amplified mana. The mana then was pressed and compressed with intense pressure, and it started to grow denser and purer. Javier shoved the mana once again.

Swoosh!

The highly purified mana that was compressed through the manaheart hung once again at the mana circle. It was amplified in that compressed state three times through the three strands of the circles. It went berserk as it rushed along his veins and muscles and cells and nerves and joints. All his senses were awakened. His energy turned fierce.

Fwoooosh!

Two contrasting auras appeared around Javier. They were sharp, clear, and vivid. But at the same time, they were soft, hazy, and vague. The two contrasting auras invaded the other's space, mixing, pulling, pushing, and resisting each other. But a second later, they collided at last.

Kaboom!

There came about a massive explosion in the sword. At the same time, an explosion similar to Javier's heart took place. It was a mana blast.

Boom!

The two strands of the mana circle crushed, wrapping around the heart, and the powerful surge of the giant mana ran along his veins like turbulent waves. They passed his hands and swirled around his sword to meet the collision of the two auras. The aura collision. Explosive mana blast. The two powers, which were likened to enraging waves, were mixed and worked to amplify each other. This explosive synergy became a torrent that swept everything away, and it came out of the sword's end to fearlessly aim at the shoulder of the dragon.

Thwack!

Javier's aura-charged mana blast, his trump card, pierced the dragon's shoulder.

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Chapter 147: Single No More (2)

Kaboom! The mana blast was laden with the aura's cutting power, splitting the air and space around it. And it finally pierced the dragon's shoulder.

"Argh...!"

Solitas screamed in spite of himself as his shoulder was penetrated. It was about a 1.6-foot hole, and of course, it was small compared to his gigantic figure. And his life wasn't in danger because the attack simply hit his shoulder. To analogize, it was as though a pencil or pen was rammed into a person's shoulder. But since it was still an injury, Solitas was in pain. Very badly. Solitas never had any instance of this kind of injury after he was born into this land as one of the proud dragons. But right now, his mouth hung wide open by the unfamiliar pain that shook him. And it was too painful to act cool and endure.

"Arggggggh!!!!!!!"

He almost teared up and wretchedly yearned for his mother. Healing magic and whatnot, nothing mattered to him at all at this moment.

"Ack!! Ughh!!"

Flustered by the sudden blow, Solitas stomped as he retreated dozens of feet. He broke out in a cold sweat in between his scales.

What on earth is that?

He was flustered and couldn't wrap his head around it. His gaze darted to Javier.

That thing is human, right?

Indeed he was. Solitas couldn't find any trace of another dragon morphed into a human. But this human just penetrated his shoulder with a long sword that was the size of a toothpick.

If the attack pierced somewhere else like my head, neck, or chest, and dug a hole in my brain or lungs...

"..."

It wouldn't end with pain. He would be in much worse trouble.

I don't get it. How is this possible? He's only a human, and I'm a dragon. How can a human pierce my shoulder in one blow?

If he were to write a novel out of it, the story would only invite mockery and scorn from his dragon readers for its ridiculousness. But such an absurd event just took place. A sense of dismay rushed through him, along with pain. And another emotion started to surge within him. Anger.

How dare he?!

Fwoosh! Solitas's eyes changed, and his enormous body was wrapped in white light. The healing magic was at work. His shoulder was treated immediately, but the magic failed to heal his pride.

Don't you dare think you'll be safe after insulting me this much!

Solitas spread his ginormous wings wide, and he hurtled as he created a storm of wind enough to send the house away. He crushed the ground, and the whole dungeon rumbled with every step he took. Solitas wiped the space where Javier was standing with his mammoth head.

Crash!

Combine the head and neck, and the length reached well over 131 feet. The blow contained that much overpowering size and weight, and strength. The ground split, the walls crashed, and the ceiling collapsed. A portion of the dungeon was destroyed to dust by one blow. But Solitas didn't stop his attack because this despicable human, who penetrated his shoulder and hurt his pride, was easily avoiding the attack.

"You flea!"

Fwish!

Like an eagle going after a fruit fly or a polar bear trying to catch snowflakes in her hands, Solitas wielded and brandished his wings and body all around. He whipped with his head and neck, leaped high with his hindlegs, scratched with his claws, and created a storm by fluttering his wings. The demolition was happening in real-time. The inside of the plaza was crushed and collapsed, but Javier evaded every single ferocious attack. He was like a mosquito hovering over someone's head during summer or fine dust penetrating a mask filter. Javier managed to avoid and evade every attack and did so with great ease.

"..."

Javier was slightly disconcerted by this. To his surprise, he wasn't going out of breath. The dragon's attack was so obvious in his eyes, and as he avoided the dragon's front leg coming down, Javier thought to himself...

Could it be that the dragon is weak? Or am I strong?

Javier couldn't point out which one was which. But there was one thing that he was certain about. Dealing with the dragon wasn't as hard as he had pegged it to be.

This fight's doable.

Javier helplessly laughed though it was faint. Right now, the enraged dragon was going berserk with his ginormous body and weight and throwing every possible attack he could manage. But Javier wasn't particularly scared or pressured. Sure, the dragon's attack was fast and powerful, but he was faster. Even though the dragon closed in on Javier with his gargantuan attacks, Javier never failed to miss his chance to escape. All he needed to do was find the dragon's blind spot and counterattack.

Jump! Javier leaped high in the air and narrowly dodged the dragon's crushing tail. He heard the crashing noise down below, and shards of rocks flew up by the impact. But Javier succeeded in reading the trajectory of every single one of the hundreds of dangerous rock pieces at once. And his

senses allowed him to react like a smooth flow of water. He stepped on seven rocks one after another as though he was climbing up a staircase in midair. He jumped, stepped, changed his direction seven times, and finally, he used the mana blast.

Boom! The repulsion power of the blast threw his body, and he was tossed to the ground. He came within a hair's breadth of getting slashed by the dragon's front leg.

Whoosh! Javier brought out his sword naturally as he saw the front leg pass him. He then summoned an aura.

Slay! Slash! He left a scratch on the dragon's front leg, skinning five layers of his scales. Blood gushed out of it.

"Eek!"

Solitas flinched his front leg after being slashed in his baby toe finger. He teared up a little at the sting. But Javier was merciless.

Slash! Clash! Slash!

Javier jumped and sat on Solitas's wrist, and he slayed him with his aura-charged sword, leaving three cut marks there.

"Ack! Ouch!"

Solitas quickly dusted off his leg and rubbed his wrist with the other leg. But Javier had already jumped and landed far away.

What the! Ack!

Solitas started to go bananas. He had heard of how humans frantically flailed about in the middle of the night in summer to catch an elusive fly during their sleep. And now, he understood what it felt like. But, no matter how many times he wielded his front legs and tried to swing his tails and wings and sweep the whole space clean, Solitas utterly failed to catch the little human.

Is he that infamous sword master? But he's so different from what my mother told me. The sword master I know about isn't this strong. He seems to be way stronger than those I'd heard of.

At the terrorizing realization, Solitas had to admit it. He can't put up a fight against this man, both in the physical and magical fight. To that man over there, he was nothing but a large punching bag, the good kind that makes people happy when they jab. As such, there was only one conclusion.

I should run.

Solitas was determined. He wasn't going to keep his pride as a dragon because he was sure that he'd die at this rate. No matter how hard he frantically tried, this human could not be caught. But, on the other hand, the man was doing clear damage to him. So, in the long run, he'd be defeated. It was the truth he didn't want to admit but had to.

My life is more valuable than my pride. He had 9,000 years more to live. So, he didn't wish to fight out of his pride and meet a meaningless death.

It's not like my pride will give me money. So it's wiser to live realistically!

So, it was decided. He had to escape before the situation got worse. Make a new dungeon in a more clandestine area. Train more and get stronger. Then, avenge.

50 years will be enough. That human brat will have weakened by then. So, I'm going to pester and harass him to the point he'll want to die and pay him back for the shame I felt today.

Since a decision was made, it was time to act. Solitas executed his escape plan right away. The first step was to let out a breath.

"You impertinent brat! Die! Hmphhh!"

Swooosh! Solitas snarled intimidatingly and drew in a large amount of air. He then mixed the mana of the dragon heart to his breath filling in his lungs. Then, let out a fiery burst of energy.

Kaboom! Fiery breath as hot as hellfire rushed out of his mouth to strike the elusive silver-haired brat. But Solitas wasn't happy. After all, the breath was just a decoy. Solitas proceeded to take the next step he had in mind.

Now!

Dash! He quickly moved his manaheart and covered the mana's arrangement he had artificially devised. At the same time, his gigantic body changed shape quickly.

Swaa...

A mysterious light enveloped his body. By the time it was gone, Solitas was already a human. Solitas just used "polymorph," which allowed him to morph into any race in the world.

Okay, time to get out!

The giant dragon was nowhere to be found now. There was only a tall red-haired young man. Solitas began to sprint toward the dungeon entrance.

Okay, faster now!

He had to get out of this dungeon before the impact of the breath he had just fired was lost and before the silver-haired man discovered his escape. He had to leave this area using teleportation as soon as he stepped out of the dungeon. That was the escape plan Solitas had in mind.

Dammit. I wish I could use teleportation magic right now, right here!

Solitas muttered to himself as he ran ahead. Teleportation allowed him to teleport anywhere in a flash, but he couldn't use it in his dungeon because he had meticulously installed the magic circle that disrupted the magic.

I was so foolish 50 years ago!

Certainly, he never imagined an event like this would occur when he first built the dungeon. It never occurred to him that he would have to abandon his dungeon to escape. So he did what the other dragons did, which

involved following the exemplary and go-to method shared with him by his mother. He only paid special attention to protecting the outside invaders by faithfully referring to them. That was the reason why he thoroughly installed a magic circle that disrupted teleportation.

Dammit. Dammit!

He couldn’t use teleportation because of the disruption, using it would only distort and jumble the coordinates. In the worst-case scenario, he’d be disintegrated into pieces and sent to all sorts of places. He knew that better than anyone and simply endeavored to run as far as he could. He ran toward the exit to survive, trusting his two solid legs. But just then, his eyes met the eyes of the man of his nightmare.

“Dragon?”

“...!”

The silver-haired knight appeared out of nowhere and had his sword pointed at Solitas. Even though he had asked a question to confirm the latter’s identity, the intruder’s eyes brimmed with confidence that the man standing in front of him was the red dragon.

“I’m not a dragon,” Solitas blurted in a hurry.

“...”

The silver-haired knight grimaced. Solitas regretted, feeling his sixth vertebrae shiver. What a buffoon! That response Solitas just gave him was totally a silly answer. And he regretted keeping his hair color red after polymorphing. But it was too late. The silver-haired knight held up his knife and brought his blade to Solitas’s neck as he walked over. Solitas could feel it.

I’m done for.

He was cornered. Now, there was no time to go back to his original shape. His head would be cut before changing back. He could resist using magic,

but it won’t do. His neck would be slayed the moment he moved his mana. The same thing would happen if he opted to ambush this human.

I barely put up a fight even when I was a dragon, so now, it’d be worse...

There was zero chance of winning.

If only I was 1,000 years older.

This kind of treatment would have been avoided if he were older. Berating his predicament, Solitas realized that his time had come. So, he prepared for the last time to resist the silver-haired knight, who was coming near. I might as well self-explode, Solitas said to himself venomously. He started to move his dragon heart little by little, rearranging his mana. The plan was to make all the mana in him collide and lead to a destructive explosion. It would be enough to wipe out this whole place. At last, when the knight came close, just three steps far...

Now!

The young dragon clenched his teeth and tightened the final trigger for self-explosion. Tears welled up in the corners of his eyes.

It’s so unfair. I’m going to explode now with a boom.

And his last moment was with no other than this despicable human. And just like that, he would perish without ever walking the aisle or dating a female dragon even once. All sorts of things he wanted to do crossed his mind. Holding front legs, walking to her dungeon and giving a kiss, exchanging love letters through telepathy, wiping the cream off the lips with dragon breath, proposing on one knee, etc... Solitas would be deprived of such sweet experiences, and he’ll end up a forever-alone bachelor dragon ghost. The thought of it made him feel cheated by life. It seemed like he would burst into tears as his eyelashes fluttered. But right before streaks of tears flowed down...

“Excuse me, Mister Dragon. Are you interested in listening to my offer? Then you’ll be able to get married within 10 years for sure.”

Just then, Solitas heard a sweet, tempting voice out of the blue.

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Chapter 148: Single No More (3)

Solitas heard a sweet temptation out of nowhere. Just hearing it sweetened his ears. Solitas flinched at the unexpected cajoling.

“What...?”

He suddenly stopped the self-explosion he had meant to activate and turned toward the voice. Another human was standing there. Solitas had seen the guy right before he fired the first breath. This man was with the silver-haired knight, and he had dark hair.

“An offer? You? To me?” asked Solitas.

“Yes. Me. To you.”

Lloyd grinned and continued to speak.

“It is just as I said a while ago. If you are interested, please hear me out.”

“So what, you can get me married in ten years if I listen to your offer?” asked Solitas.

“Indeed.”

“How do I trust you?” Solitas grimaced as he alternately looked at Javier and Lloyd, who were both standing in his front and back. “To be honest, I was tempted to listen to you, but I simply can’t trust you. Think about it. You two are intruders who invaded my dungeon.”

“Excuse me? Intruders? No way.”

Lloyd noticed that Solitas’s eyes grew rough, so he licked his lips.

“I came here bearing a good offer and nothing more.”

“Ha! Bullcrap. Then why did you break down all the magic traps?” blurted Solitas.

“To live,” said Lloyd matter-of-factly.

“What?”

“The magic circles were too delicately laid,” defended Lloyd, “They were too fatal. So, I had no choice and did my best to survive. And in the process, I had to damage some of your traps. I offer my sincere apology if it upset you. I profusely apologize.”

“What...”

Solitas was out of words to rebut. The words this man was uttering made sense. And before Solitas could come up with a likely response, Lloyd intercepted the chance and spoke first.

“Anyway, that is why I worked our butt off to get here. To make you a nice offer.”

“And what could that be?” Solitas spoke with hesitation in his voice.

“Don’t you want to learn how to process jewels from a great craftsman?”

“What?” Solitas flinched, his eyes growing wide.

“I will get right down to business,” Lloyd hurriedly said, “my respectable dragon, I know your concern. You have clumsy hands, don’t you? You have been having trouble with processing jewels, and so you have been unable to save any treasures and were disheartened because you failed to get married. Am I wrong?”

“How did you...” murmured Solitas in disbelief.

“That problem can be fixed. It’s okay that you’re not so crafty. It can be worked with. That is, by receiving strenuous training from a great master for about ten years. Then, you’ll be able to master how to process raw minerals,” suggested Lloyd.

“H-hold on. Hold on,” Solitas stopped Lloyd just then, and with eyes filled with fright, he asked, “How did you know that I was clumsy and having

issues with my marriage? How? How?”

Solitas was flustered and unsettled. He had never engaged with humans before; it had been only about 50 years since he became a grown-up dragon. That meant he had never had any experience or encounter with humans, not to mention other dragons or similar races. But here was a human who knew his exact personal concern. In fact, he couldn’t be any more right about it.

What in the world is this human?

Solitas couldn’t wrap his head around how a mere human was aware of his personal concern. Was he a ghost? Or was he an old dragon disguised as a human? Or was he a great magician or prophet who had reached the highest possible intellectual limit? Solitas was mixed with emotions. Caution and curiosity rushed through him. Lloyd smiled respectfully.

“It was not hard to find out,” stated Lloyd.

“How so?”

“The knight of blood and iron has told me.”

“The knight of the blood and iron?” repeated Solitas.

“Yes.”

“Who... is he?”

“A massively powerful knight. So strong and powerful that he can surveil this place, fooling your senses,” explained Lloyd.

“That’s a lie,” defied Solitas as he wrinkled his nose. “You are lying to me. A human can never be that strong. How can anyone slip out so furtively that my senses don’t pick it up? That is impossible. Do you think such a human exists?”

“Yes, I do,” answered Lloyd.

“How?”

“Did you not see that friend over there?”

Lloyd spoke nonchalantly before pointing at Javier.

“I am sure you can remember,” continued Lloyd, “how he managed to put up a great fight against you with nothing but a sword.”

“That’s because...”

“The knight of blood and iron is stronger than him,” Lloyd said with finality in his voice.

Of course, it was true. When Javier held the title of the “Knight of the Blood and Iron” in the novel, he was stronger than his present self. He was already a grandmaster. He had six circles, and fooling a fledgling dragon was a piece of cake.

“The knight has told me that there is a dungeon in this place but without any treasures. But even the small amount of collected ones are terrible in quality,” said Lloyd.

“So what, you just speculated about my situation based on his story?” Solitas said.

“Yes,” said Lloyd as he nodded. His voice now brimmed with confidence. “How can I dare then guess your predicament and concern in any other way?”

The aforementioned knight was a fabricated figure. He was the Javier that existed in a novel that wasn’t written in this world. So, what Lloyd was saying was actually a bluff. But there was no way Solitas could check whether he was lying or not. As such, Lloyd knew that he had to be more confident at a time like this. That way, the bluff that was likely to be called would be unquestioned and believable.

“Hmm...”

A deep wrinkle sat in between Solitas’s forehead. Doubt, concern, curiosity, and interest all fought in his head. Solitas wondered if he could trust this

human and whether he was telling the truth. But something in his words was too convincing to dismiss it as a lie.

He hit the nail on the head when he spoke of my concern.

His clumsy hands prevented him from processing pieces of minerals and accumulating treasures. And his bleak prospect of staying single forever hurt and wrung his heart. Yet, this human boasted that he could solve his very secret that no one could've found out about unless they had spied on the inside of his dungeon. And so, what this dark-haired figure was ridiculously saying could be true. But Solitas wanted more confirmation first as it wouldn't hurt him anyway. So, Solitas made a decision after some thinking.

"So you came here with a good offer?" said Solitas.

"Yes, I did."

Gotcha, you're mine, dragon. Convinced, Lloyd put on a beaming smile written with the words "trust, faithfulness, and honesty." He salivated his lips. Javier was watching the whole thing and thought to himself...

Knight of blood and iron?

He had heard of the name before. Lloyd had mentioned it last time.

I wonder who that is.

Javier was curious. The knight was said to be stronger than him, but he had never heard of him even once.

Is he a nameless fellow who trains, shunning the world? That makes it even stranger. Why would such a man secretly help Master Lloyd?

The knight was said to be more powerful than him and have secret communication with Lloyd. However, Javier thought those two points didn't add up.

It’s strange. Really. Plus, I’ve never seen Master Lloyd meeting someone behind my back. Did he meet the knight after putting me to sleep with his lullaby?

The more he thought about it, he became nonplussed. At the same time, however, he didn’t consider the knight to be a fabricated figure. It was so because of the image he had built of Lloyd.

After all, he doesn’t operate based on untrustworthy information and plan.

To Javier, Lloyd was a small-hearted man who was stingy, fastidious, and sly. He also was the type to work his ass off to make sure things would always be advantageous for him. In other words, he was a cowardly man. It was a universal law that a timorous man tended to be more careful.

Master Lloyd is a fastidious and meticulous man. He never makes a move based on untrustworthy information and plans. Never. He’d think that would hurt him. So, it only means that Master Lloyd knew in advance of the dragon dungeon situation. He must have gotten some tips from a reliable source and operated after careful planning.

And the plan was happening right now.

So that only means that the knight of the blood and iron, who had tipped Master Lloyd, is an actual living person.

Javier wondered who on earth this knight was. The more speculative he became, the more he became curious. On the one hand, he was slightly awed by Lloyd for the simple fact that the latter was trying to strike a deal with the dragon.

He used the information to design this whole thing.

Master Lloyd brought him here to fight the dragon, and Javier managed to suppress the dragon and stamped in the latter’s memory that Javier held the upper hand in the fight, breaking the pride unique to dragons. Afterward, Lloyd proceeded to offer a sweet deal, showcasing his brilliant eloquence.

That silver tongue itself alone is a weapon.

But Master Lloyd’s eloquence didn’t appear randomly. He always first created an environment and situation that would make his eloquence 100% effective. The man always struck a perfectly crafted deal. That was why he was able to see such massive and efficient results.

Regardless, he’s a scary being.

And now, the poor dragon was falling into Lloyd's trap. Javier gazed at Solitas with a sympathetic gaze. Right now, Solitas was almost buying what Lloyd was saying.

“It is just as I have said. You are going to learn from the best craftsman. You will be his apprentice,” said Lloyd.

“An apprentice of a master?”

“Yes. You see, a great master lives in my fiefdom.”

“Who is that?” asked Solitas.

“He is Wels Corgidus, the royal dwarf master.”

“He’s a dwarf, eh? And his name is Corgidus?”

Solitas’s eyes trembled a bit. Since Corgidus was both a master and dwarf, there wasn’t any need to verify his skills. Obviously, the man was to be the best of the best.

“Then... I am supposed to be the dwarf’s apprentice and learn how to process the stones?”

“Yes. Tell me, is your pride hurt?”

“Hmm...”

To be honest, his pride hurt a little, but when he heard what Lloyd said after, his thoughts changed.

“Just bend your pride a little, and you’ll soon have a girlfriend. Become rich, get married, and have a lovey-dovey newlywed life. You’ll have children and start a happy family.”

“Is that so?” asked Solitas, intrigued. “And go on a honeymoon?”

“No need to ask such an obvious question.”

“...”

Breathing became heavier for Solitas. But he recovered composure being the dragon he was.

“Hmm, your offer is good indeed, and that’s why I am still doubtful,” said Solitas.

“Doubtful? How so?”

“Because it appears that you are giving me too much. I am sure you have something you want from me?”

“Of course,” said Lloyd, “I was just about to tell you.”

“Do tell.”

“Yes. I shall be straightforward. I want you to use your breath every once a month in a place near my fiefdom.”

“You want me to use my breath...?”

“Yes.”

Solitas was confused because he didn’t understand Lloyd right away. So, Lloyd continued to speak.

“My fiefdom is planning to build sewers. It’s a facility that divides, separates, and treats all sorts of sewage and bodily wastes through underground tunnels.”

“So?”

“It will leave a massive load of residue called sludge in the process.”

“Could you mean-”

“Yes,” said Lloyd, “You are a dragon. You guessed it already. And your guess is indeed correct.”

“Do you want me to burn this sludge with my breath?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded his head.

“The amount is just too much to treat and incinerate with my hands. It’s difficult and dangerous. But with your breath, all it takes is ten seconds. You can easily turn the sludge into ash.”

Lloyd was telling the truth. No matter how much he racked his brain, there simply wasn’t any way to treat the sludge. It was so even when he mobilized magicians.

Even the hellish fire magic by the best palatial magicians won’t do.

Sure, the hellish fire magic would be scorchingly hot, but it barely lasted a few seconds. The range of such magic was also narrow, so it would be needed more than once to take care of the sludge. There was also a chance of splattering the dirty and messy sludge. On the other hand, the dragon breath was different.

The temperature is just incredible.

Plus, its range and the time the high heat lasted were just on another level. In other words, one breath every month was enough to turn the piles of sludge into ash.

Then, I’ll be able to use them as fertilizers.

That was Lloyd’s plan. To actualize his plan, he finalized his pitch.

“If you consider the job of taking care of the sludge dirty, then I guess I cannot help you. You can turn down my offer and live the rest of your life in this dim dungeon forever alone.”

“...”

Forever alone. That gripped Solitas’s heart.

C-crap.

Hesitation gripped Solitas. The offer this human was making required him to break his pride twice. Once by being an apprentice of the dwarf master. Second by taking care of the sludge left by the bodily waste. But if he swallowed his pride...

I can live the rest of my life in happiness.

Successful courtship and marriage. The dream he has yearned for so direly would come true.

Should I give it... a try?

Solitas was intrigued. Of course, he was completely in the dark about what fate awaited him in the novel as well as how he confronted Javier regarding the woods of the elves. And how in the end, Javier cut his horn and made him run for his life. And how he met a tragic end after living 500 years in bitterness. But right now, instead of that life, he was put on a sweet path of new choices thanks to Lloyd. Solitas finally made the decision that would change his fate.

“All right. I shall take up your offer.”

“You made the right choice.”

Flap! Lloyd beamed as he took out a piece of document. It was the symbol of capitalism he had planned in advance for this moment. This paper was more grounded and wretched than a magical pact and not even humans, orcs, elves, and dragons could ever evade it. It was an outsourcing employment contract.

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Chapter 149: Construction Guideline (1)

One day later. Lloyd, Javier, and Solitas returned to Frontera county. The trip was a breeze, thanks to Solitas, who teleported both of them with his magic. All they did was step out of the dungeon, stand out of the disruptive magic circle's influence, and allow Solitas to transport them to their destination. Then, after some flashes, crackles, and momentary pangs of nausea, a familiar scene appeared in front of

“Welcome to Frontera county,” Lloyd said.“Please, follow me this way.”

Lloyd then guided Solitas to Corgidus, the dwarf master. As soon as Lloyd saw Corgidus, he immediately requested Solitas for a place here.

“Excuse me, master Corgidus,” Lloyd called.

“Why are you here? I am swamped with work,” the dwarf curtly replied.

“Of course, I understand that you’re busy. But this affair pertains to what I have told you before,” said Lloyd further.

“What you have told me before?” Corgidus, who was clanging his metal hammer aloud at length, said as he lifted his head. When he saw Solitas behind Lloyd, he raised his brows.

“I have never seen that face around here before,” he continued. “Is he-”

“Yes, he is the one,” said Lloyd. “You have accepted my request before, right? My request about how I asked you to take up an apprentice.”

It really was the case. Lloyd succeeded in persuading Corgidus in advance prior to leaving for the dragon dungeon. With expensive wine and delicious snacks in his embrace, Lloyd groveled as he drank together with the dwarf. And he made sure to inflate Corgidus’s pride as a master until the atmosphere ripened and Corgidus became a happy drunk. Lloyd then sneakily asked for a favor, how there is this young man who is very clumsy with his craft. He asked the dwarf if he could help this unfortunate

youngster to get better. But of course, Corgidus flatly turned him down. Corgidus said that he despised the mere thought of having an apprentice under him. It was a fruitless and bothersome endeavor.

But Lloyd's response to Corgidus's rejection was unusual. With a solemn look on his face, Lloyd spoke straightforwardly and explained that this young man was actually a dragon. And the fiefdom was in need of that dragon's help. But it can only happen if the dragon was properly compensated with a reward, which was the teachings of the master, that is, Corgidus. It was rare for Lloyd to be this forthright, but it worked. No, who knows, maybe it was Lloyd's usual propriety and cap-in-hand attitude toward Corgidus that worked. Nevertheless, Corgidus accepted the offer. This was the event a few days ago.

"So... the one who stands behind you is the gentleman you mentioned the last time?" Corgidus said.

Corgidus knew that Solitas wasn't a human but a dragon, which was the race that was almost an enemy because it had enslaved a legion of dwarf masters in the distant past. Just then, a glint of naughtiness appeared in Corgidus's gaze.

"So, to borrow the expression of this young master, I heard that you are a helpless clumsy fellow, eh?" teased Corgidus.

"..."

Solitas nodded, his cheeks blushing red. But it was a mystery why it happened. It could be because of the truth bomb Corgidus just hauled at him. Or it could be because of the shameful reality that he had to stoop down to become an apprentice of a dwarf. Or it could be out of the awkwardness of being in a place other than the dragon dungeon. No one knew except for this dragon himself. Whatever the case was, Solitas behaved with courtesy and gentleness, which was surprising.

"Yes, and I came here prepared," Solitas said. "I am ready to lay aside my pride, so please teach me."

“It wouldn’t be easy even for the master to deliver the man from the curse of clumsy hands. Expect to be scolded, as it will happen a lot,” warned Corgidus.

“I expected nothing less. No, I expect nothing less,” said Solitas.

Going out on a date and getting married. Solitas had made the resolution to be humble to live a life of a happy dragon. He was willing to bear the brunt of learning from the dwarf. And besides, this figure was set to save him from the misery of being a poor craftsman. Solitas thought that this dwarf deserved to be treated as his master.

“Good,” said Corgidus.

A content smile appeared in between his beard. From that day on, Solitas became an apprentice to Corgidus. He was made to spend in the latter’s lodging and learned to process the jewels. Of course, the process involved all sorts of scolding. Nagging was an everyday event. There were also times when Corgidus reamed Solitas out so much that the dragon teared up. But Solitas never ever talked back to his master. He instead quietly put more effort, softly comforting himself that all of these were for getting into a relationship. Overcome this, and it was farewell to forever single. And because he stayed quiet and wordless, nobody knew that he was a dragon, minus Lloyd, Javier, and Corgidus. The rest of the people in the fiefdom simply regarded him as a red-haired young man who learned things from Corgidus with daily scolding and nagging. Anyway, Lloyd was relieved after he saw that he had successfully recruited Solitas.

It’s completed. I have the laborers, stones, and sludge treatment for the sewer construction. Every element is in place.

The sewer had to be constructed before the winter. That was the only way to prevent the spread of the infectious disease that would plague the whole fiefdom the following spring. So with that determination in mind, Lloyd swung into action and knuckled down to design the project. But before that, he didn’t forget to upgrade his design skills.

This project covers a vast area. No. It's super vast as it's happening across the whole fiefdom.

As such, the current intermediate-level design skill wasn't enough. He needed to improve his skill to design the whole place in one go.

Designing is quite different from surveying. For the latter, I can attain topographical data by simply looking around the place several times even if the range is limited. But it's not the case with the design. The data doesn't get picked up automatically. I'll have to design everything one by one.

But if the design range was narrow, Lloyd had to stop midway when he was designing very well.

To analogize, it'd be like the difference between automatic and manual transmission. Surveying gathers the data all by itself once I use the skill. But the design requires me to manipulate the data laboriously one by one. It's like pressing the clutch each time I change the manual transmission.

In actuality, it was more laborious than what he described. What was worse was that the design was prone to error when the design skill is used more frequently.

Even a tiny mistake is impermissible to this project. The moment the waste water leaks from the sewer, I'm done for.

Once it does, it will seep into the underground and contaminate the underground water. Then, it would be the start of the epidemic, a reenactment of what Lloyd had seen in the Ending Spoiler.

I can't let that happen. So, I should level up since it's been a while since I did.

Thinking that leveling up may be more convenient and reduce the possibility of making mistakes, Lloyd opened the skill window and selected the design skill in the list.

Ding Dong.

A detailed information of the design skill appeared.

[Intermediate Design: Lv 6]

[Volume of structure that can be projected at once: 729,000]

[Skill Options: ① Map Printing ② Floor Plan Marking (2D) ③ Simulation Mode]

[Required RP to level up: 200]

I'm already at intermediate level 6.

Lloyd didn't invest his RP to level up. But because he had finished several large-scale construction projects, the skill leveled up on its own.

Okay, time to splurge my RP now.

The job involved spending a large amount of RP, which was as precious as gold and his own blood. Lloyd breathed in and out first before clicking on the "Skill Level Up" menu.

[You are leveling up the design skill to <Intermediate Level 7.>]

[Required RP to level up: 200]

[Current RP: 4,070]

[Proceed and level up the skill?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a yes.

As soon as Lloyd nodded...

Ding Dong!

A message appeared along with a pleasing dinging noise.

[Skill Level Up!]

[Intermediate Design: Lv 7]

[Volume of structure that can be projected at once: 1,000,000]

[Skill Options: ① Map Printing ② Floor Plan Marking (2D) ③ Simulation Mode]

[Required RP to level up: 220]

He leveled up, and the design range increased. But he didn't intend to stop with this.

Duh. I should do it right while I'm at it. That is until my level is raised.

Since he was investing anyway, he might as well do so until his class increases and he gets a new optional skill. Soon, the level reached 7 and 8 and until 10. And when he invested 280 RP once more, the message Lloyd finally waited for appeared in front of his eyes.

Ding Dong.

[Skill Class Level Up!]

[Your skill class has reached <Advanced>.]

[A new skill option has been made available following your change in skill class.]

[Advanced Design: Lv 1]

[Volume of structure that can be projected at once: 3,375,000]

[Skill Options: ① Map Printing ② Floor Plan Marking (2D) ③ Simulation Mode ④ Construction Guideline]

[Required RP to level up: 500]

[Current RP: 2,870]

Perfect.

Lloyd clenched his fists. The design's volume was four times wider, which set him back about 1,200 RP. But Lloyd now had a new optional skill.

Optional skill is important. What is this? Construction Guideline?

Lloyd opened the window to learn more about the optional skill.

[Skill Option 4: Construction Guideline - The blueprint you have designed is marked in the actual terrain in the form of the guideline. This guideline will be visible not only to the designer but also to the workers on the site, and the workers will learn in real-time whether they are faithfully adhering to the blueprint (The Construction Guideline is synced to ② Floor Plan Marking (2D.).]

What the heck?

Lloyd read the description once again, and that enlightened him a little more about what this new optional skill could do.

So, the floor plan marking only I could see will previously be visible to the workers from now on. At the same time, they will receive immediate notice whether the construction is taking place according to the blueprint.

Lloyd thought this skill was something. If it could do just what the description said, the work efficiency will jump to a whole new degree. Expectant, Lloyd rose up and stepped out of bed.

Let's see what it does.

Lloyd made for the training hall, and he saw Javier training hard under the searing sun all alone. He called for him.

"What brings you here at this hour?" said Javier.

"Why else? I came to see you," said Lloyd.

“...”

“What? Why? What? What’s so dissatisfying that you’re narrowing your eyes and glaring at me like that?” blurted Lloyd.

“I just can’t trust you.”

“Trust me?”

“Yes,” Javier said. “I am simply wondering what underlying motive you have this time.”

“Oh, are you trying to tell me that we’re the kind of people who never talk unless we want something?” asked Lloyd.

“Obviously,” Javier said as he wiped his forehead with a towel and folded it in half. “Please tell me what business you came here for.”

“All right. Shovel the ground for me,” said Lloyd without beating around the bush.

“Excuse me...?” Javier paused and cocked his head to the side. “You want me to shovel, young master?”

“Yeah,” Lloyd confirmed, “Here, take this first.”

Dazed, Javier took the shovel. Then, Lloyd spoke to Javier.

“Will you please dig up here?” said Lloyd as he pointed at the center of the training hall.

Javier frowned a little before he said, “Why are you telling me to shovel the center of the training hall out of the blue? Could you please at least tell me why?”

“Nah, I can’t.”

“...”

“Dig and you’ll find out. Just dig now. Trust me.”

“Whew.”

Javier sighed at length. He was actually gaining focus on his personal training after a while. The lessons he had learned from the battle against the red dragon were returning to him in the process. But here came this small-hearted young master disrupting him with his absurd instruction.

I should finish it quickly.

Javier decided to finish it fast because he had to do it anyway. Fixing his posture and grabbing the shovel, Javier got into action. He even harnessed the Asrahan Core Technique.

Crash!

It was the shoveling of a sword master. Even when the force was light, the shovel's head penetrated the ground very deeply. It was like Javier was scooping rice from a bowl of bulgogi rice with his spoon. Much to his surprise, Javier caught a streak of “line” in the ground sometime later.

Eh?

This line was blue and straight, drawn horizontally across the ground. But it looked strange no matter how hard he perceived it. It wasn’t a dye. It wasn’t a thread, either.

It’s light.

It was bright blue light. However, Javier could not identify its source. And since it was light, he couldn’t even erase it if he touched it with his shovel.

What’s happening...?

Flustered, Javier turned and looked at Lloyd. But the latter simply instructed with his gaze to keep shoveling.

“You see a mark, no? Will you keep digging following the line?”

“...”

Curious, Javier maneuvered his shovel to check what it was. He kept digging on and on, following the visible blue line. Later, an outline started to form with the blue line. He then dug following the outline. A shape, which the line formed, appeared. It turned out to be a cube, taking up a huge space in the ground. It was 6.5 x 6.5, and its volume was 8 . And so, his efforts of digging up the earth to the light resulted in a sleek, perfect cubic hole.

“What on earth is this?” asked Javier. The question came out of him involuntarily. Lloyd, who was looking down at Javier on the ground, spoke.

“It’s a construction guideline,” he said nonchalantly.

“Excuse me?”

Javier tilted his head in confusion.

From then on...

“So, what I’m saying is...”

Lloyd flapped his lips to tell a preposterous lie, and he chuckled as he looked at Javier. Javier was staring at him. And just then, for some mysterious reason, it dawned on Javier that Master Lloyd was always the same and unchanging. In moments like these, he always told white lies.

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Chapter 150: Construction Guideline (2)

“Do you remember the last time we constructed the seokbinggo for the orc village? And how we executed the dark magician?” Lloyd asked.

Javier nodded. “Yes, I do.”

“Do you recall how we tore the whole place down and grabbed every magical material?” said Lloyd.

“Yes, of course.”

“I came across something amazing among the junk. This one. When I implanted mana, it turned out that I could create an illusion.”

Lloyd held out his hand, holding a round medal in it.

“So, did you draw the cube of light under the ground using that medal?” asked Javier.

“Yeah,” said Lloyd. “I thought it’d be handy to mark out the blueprint in the construction down the road. It will allow the workers to work conveniently.”

“What an amazing function,” stated Javier.

“Right? Me too. There’s more. Can you scoop up an area? Just once.”

“Anywhere?”

“Yeah,” said Lloyd. “Anywhere.”

“…”

Javier stared at Lloyd and stole a glance at the medal. Javier instantly knew. Sure, the medal was a magical trinket, but it was a lie that Master Lloyd had drawn the blue light and side in the earth with that medal.

“...”

Javier wondered if he should let it slide this time as well. After some hesitation, Javier silently held up the shovel and stuck it in one area inside the cube cave. A large dent appeared on one of the perfectly-straight sides. Then, something happened.

Beep!

The sharp beeping was followed by a change of color on the side. It turned red.

“Did you see that?” said Lloyd. “It notifies the worker once they deviate from the design.”

“Then...”

“They’ll quickly know if they’re not doing something right.”

“To me, it sounds like they will not be lazing around anymore.”

“But,” Lloyd said, “I make sure they’re well provided for, don’t I?” He plastered a smile commonly visible among vicious employers. He had wondered how the new optional skill, which he attained by increasing his skill class, would work. But when he tested it out, it turned out to be dynamite.

So, the blueprint I designed has been projected to the ground just the same. And it notifies the error in real-time.

The thing with the construction project was that it held a possibility of being a total failure if the workers did a horrible job. It was the case even when the design was perfect and meticulous to the hilt. Intentional ignorance of a design or busy work was actually quite common in construction sites. After all, it involved people.

But now, I can prevent that from happening. Any deviation from the blueprint is highlighted in color.

What was more, Lloyd was now able to designate the margin of error and standard permissible to him by marking them in red. As such, this optional skill allowed Lloyd to worry no more. It would be more so as he proceeded with this project, which required stringent precision and attention to detail.

And my story about the magical item and whatnot seemed to have worked.

Lloyd was relieved. He thought he had fooled Javier. So, everything was now all set. The time had come to take this construction to full swing.

***

The construction took off seamlessly.

“Now, I am sure you know very well what you all must do.”

The site selected for the first excavation was the area near the central village of the fiefdom. There, Sir Bayern gave a solemn speech.

“We have completed various projects under the supervision of our young master Lloyd Frontera. We have constructed countless ondol rooms, turned the Maritz Wetlands into fertile land, and built waterways that run from the high eastern mountain range to our fiefdom.”

As Sir Bayern enumerated the projects he and his engineering corp participated in, his face reflected with a swelling sense of pride.

“But that is not the end of it,” continued Sir Bayern. “The large apartment complex is currently under construction as per the design of Master Lloyd, and through the winter, we carved up the slopes in the eastern range and built up retaining walls to turn them into abundant terraced fields. And now! We are holding our shovels high to achieve something that surpasses all that we ever did.”

A sense of pride rushed through the engineers as they listened to the speech. Each of their uniforms was donned with varying embroideries, symbolizing the construction projects each had participated in. They were the medal of hard work and the proof of their career.

“Indeed. We will make history today. As we actualize the blueprint of Master Lloyd, and for the bright future of the fiefdom, on our honor, we shout! Safety first!”

“Safety first! Wow!!”

The forceful shout signaled the beginning of the construction. The seasoned engineer corp played a critical role and led the construction, while countless refugees and residents, who had volunteered for Lloyd, acted as their support. On top of that, the construction guideline ensured the job was convenient and precise.

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!”

Swish! Swish! Swish!

A large amount of dirt was scooped up each time Ppodong wiggled his butt. Just like that, a 13 x 13 hole that was 6.5 feet deep came to be. The engineers and workers who were watching the sight started to murmur among themselves.

“Over there, what on earth is that in the ground? I see a blue light,” a refugee old man murmured to himself.

An engineer soldier grinned at his side.

“Oh, that? That’s the guideline Master Lloyd drew out under the earth.”

“A guide...line?”

“Yes,” he confirmed.

“What does that do?” asked the curious old man.

“It shows exactly where to dig and where to avoid.”

“How is that possible?” he added.

“Well, I don’t know, but it’s visible to our eyes because it’s possible. I don’t know the mechanism behind it. Anyway, Master Lloyd says that we simply have to dig and build following that mark,” said the young man with a shrug.

“Haha, my goodness. How amazing.”

The civil engineer soldiers were briefed about the guideline before working. And the workers, who heard the same thing from the engineers, were amazed. The construction guideline grew more vivid as they looked at it. But they soon learned that it was a bit different from their expectations. It showed more than the outline, area, and depth to excavate. It was more detailed and elaborate. Even the location and range of the bricks to be stacked inside the hole became visible. It was as though a 3D blueprint hologram was installed inside.

“My goodness, it’s much more detailed than I had thought!”

The workers were astonished by how exhaustive the whole thing was. Just like that, they jumped into action, fine-pressing the shaft Ppodong had dug. Built in the central village of the fiefdom, it was meant to collect all sorts of sewage and bodily wastes people disposed of in the area.

It’d have been nice if I could build a modern sewage system in each household where they can directly throw their waste.

But he didn’t have the technology to do so and lacked money, time, and labor. A bitter smile appeared on Lloyd’s face as he looked at the ongoing construction. To be honest, he wanted to create a modern sewage system, just like the one in South Korea, if he could. It would allow the water used at homes to pass through the sewers and the people to flush their toilets. Clean and sleek. Lloyd wanted to devise a method wherein people could deal with the waste without extra effort or care.

But that’s impossible here.

To construct a modern sewage system, Lloyd had to connect the residential facility with underground pipes. But the current situation made it

impossible for him to do so. Soon, the freezing winter would turn the Prona River into a giant block of ice. The accumulated bodily waste there signaled a large-scale epidemic. So, the sewers had to be constructed before the plague, leaving Lloyd no time to build and connect houses with pipes. He would need at least several years to perfect such a thorough system.

That's why I'm constructing a large sewage shaft in each village and region.

The sewage and bodily waste excreted from each household would be thrown into the shaft, and they would flow through the connected pipes to gather in one place. That was the crux of the sewage system Lloyd planned on constructing.

That would save me time and effort as well.

At the moment, Lloyd needed to opt for the most cost-effective method. With such a motto in mind, Lloyd led and supervised the construction. The earth was dug for the sewage shaft, and the ground was refined and processed. And he coated the shaft with granite bricks and cement to ensure that the sewage and bodily waste wouldn't seep underground. Then, he connected the sewage pipes for the sewage to flow out.

The ground was dug in an elongated manner, 16 feet deep. The floor received a thick coating of sand and rubble. Then, it was covered with flat granite plates to prevent the leaching of contaminated sewage. On top of the plates, a layer of cement was plastered, and granite bricks were placed to interlock one another. The bottom side of the sewage pipe was made to be shaped in a reversed egg, as this tapered design ensured a faster and more seamless flow of the sewage downward. These pipes were exactly 6.5 feet wide and high. On its side was a 23-inch pedestrian where people could pass by. And the area with finished pipes was completed with granite bricks and water-proofed. Then, they were covered with sand.

The maintenance hole worked as a staircase, from which the workers could safely travel down to the sewer if there were any clogging or leakage. It looked like just the "Cholera Canal," the sewage in Vienna, Austria. The first section was composed of the sewage treatment facility, which sat at the

central village of the fiefdom, and the sewer leading from it. The construction took 20 days to finish. But it wasn't over.

Of course. This is just the beginning. All I did was construct the facility for one village. The real deal is the one we'll be building from now on.

The sewage and bodily waste would flow through the sewage treatment facility and sewer built in each village and apartment building, and they would finally stream out of the fiefdom through the main sewer. The construction of the main sewer took place. It was the extra-large version of the aforementioned Cholera Canal. Bibeong was mobilized for this project as well.

"Bibebeong! Bibeong!"

Stomp Stomp!

Bibeong stomped down the mountain. It had been a while, so he was excited to be here. He stole a glance at Bangul, who was sitting on Lloyd's shoulder in the distance. His heart fluttered with butterflies at the sight of his first love, and his cheeks blushed red. He moved his 3,000-ton front legs with all his might.

"Bibeong!"

Boom! Crash!

The ground was dug as though a gigantic excavator was at work. In a flash, Bibeong excavated a 65 x 65-foot hole. The engineers and workers were put to work just like that as they built sewer pipes. A ginormous main sewer, 32 feet in width and 26 feet in height, was dredged along with a 9.8-foot pedestrian zone on the side. The major sewer faced extended north. Each day, it got longer. The spring rain stopped the flowering of plants. Frogs croaked aloud. Roses bloomed their first petals. Three months later, the main sewer passed beyond the northern area of the fiefdom.

"Now, you must be careful from now on," intervened Lloyd, "I am sure you can remember. Do you know which direction the Mastodons charged after it

ambushed our fiefdom because of the monster domino phenomenon?”

“To the north, young master!” The soldiers answered in unison at Lloyd’s question. The experience of driving the herd of Mastodons to the north using the river water clearly left an unforgettable impression on their minds.

“Good. I am glad that you can still remember. As you know, Mastodons are powerful animals. Sweeping them with the river water simply doesn’t kill them. Almost all of them would have survived after being swept away to this place and starting a new life here. In other words, we’re trespassing their territory and building something here.”

Lloyd continued to warn them.

“So, all you must be on your toes. Surely, Bibeong is here to deter them from attacking us so easily. But there are exceptions. Even if you take a rest, don’t go far away from the site, and if you have to go far for some inevitable reason, go by grouping yourselves into ten. Got it?”

“Yes, young master!”

The construction resumed after the warning speech. But to Lloyd’s surprise and embarrassment, not a single Mastodon was found even when the construction reached the tenth day since the trespass.

Whew, this is embarrassing. Did I give a speech for nothing?

Lloyd chuckled to himself, thinking that the Mastodons must have settled farther than he expected. Or it could be that Bibeong’s presence was deterring them from approaching.

If that’s the case, then it’s good for us.

Things were always better if they didn’t encounter dangerous monsters. It was especially so amid the noisy and chaotic construction site. However, around the time Lloyd was putting his guard down, something happened.

“Bibebeong? Bibeong!”

Bibeong, who was digging the ground, yelled. But his shout was suggestive. It meant, “Over here! Something’s here!”

Hmm? Something’s there?

What could it be? Lloyd wondered to himself. Jostling out of his trance, Lloyd headed in the direction of the calling and looked at the area Bibeong was pointing at. The ground was being dug up. But underneath the piles of dirt, an outline of something appeared in his view.

“Mastodon?”

It was a carcass, buried about 22 feet deep. But it wasn’t very rotten. In other words, it was killed just recently.

What the heck? Why is it buried 22 feet underground?

A landslide? Lloyd postulated to himself, but that wasn’t possible.

This area is a plain.

His next guess was the other Mastodons burying this carcass.

No, it can’t be.

Mastodons were monsters, so they didn’t have the intelligence to bury the dead. Soon, another strange thing happened.

“Bibeong? Bibeo-beong?”

Bibeong, who was looking at the carcass as he cocked his head, moved his front leg and carefully scooped the area next to it. Another carcass appeared. But there was more.

“What...”

As Bibeong continued to dig, dead Mastodons kept appearing without stopping. Ten? Twenty? No. More than a hundred.

“Bibeong! Bibeo-beong?”

“Yes, um, I’m looking at it as well. I can also see that they were carefully buried in a straight line, as though someone put in the effort to do so. What in the world is this...”

Lloyd couldn’t wrap his head around this. His mind flew back to the stories in the novel, but it never mentioned the clean burial of the Mastodons. The only similar incident as this one was about the Namaran’s Wall episode, wherein Javier learned how to use the mana blast. Just then...

Pshhh!

Amid the piles of dead Mastodons, an eerie and ominous noise pierced Lloyd’s ears.

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Chapter 151: Runaway (1)

Pshhh!

There came an ominous sound. It was small and faint at first, but it gradually grew louder until everyone could hear it.

“What is it?”

The civil engineers, who were watching Bibeong excavate, cocked their heads to the side. Something strange was happening as hundreds of Mastodon carcasses were unearthed, all neatly lined up. This unexpected event was enough to make the workers curious. Soon, the White Cavalry and the refugees gathered around the hole as well, murmuring among themselves.

“What’s that noise?”

“I don’t know. Maybe it’s the sound of the stench coming out.”

“Stench?”

“You know, like how cows and pigs get all bloated with gas in their stomachs when their dead remains are left alone for a long time.”

“Aha. I’ve seen it as well. Their stomach inflates like a balloon and bursts with a pop.”

“Indeed. I think that’s what’s happening right now.”

“Could it be that they’re bursting now as we remove the dirt that pressed them down?”

“Probably?”

“Ha! This is going to be the most entertaining thing I’ve seen in a while.”

The engineers, the White Cavalry, and refugee workers observed the sight with a glimmer in their eyes. An air of expectation hung in the area as everyone anticipated what clamorous noise these huge Mastodons would make when their stomachs burst. Even the small dead cows and pigs gave a popping noise, which sounded like a beat of a drum when their stomachs blew up. Everyone was excited except one person.

That's strange.

A bad feeling gripped Lloyd, but he couldn't pinpoint why. These hundreds of Mastodons were buried in one clean line, but they didn't die naturally. It was someone's doing for sure.

Who could have done it?

Lloyd had no way of knowing, but something was loud and clear.

The carcasses have all decomposed similarly. Then it means that they were killed all around the same time. If that's the case, it could only mean...

Someone killed them on purpose. Hundreds of Mastodons were slaughtered in a short period of time. This was an act with clear intention.

But why? To what end?

There was no way of knowing that either. But at that moment, the Asrahan Core Technique worked to strike him with a realization. The bad feeling that stung his heart wasn't a simple, groundless prediction.

Eh?

Lloyd suddenly felt a flow of mana, and through the Asrahan Core Technique, he detected an abnormal strand of mana. And as though a magic circle was sucking the mana from the Mastodons, an abnormally large concentration of mana started to develop. At the same time, the sound of gas leaking amplified from the carcass. That only meant one thing.

"Everybody back off!" Lloyd yelled.

The workers turned to look at him with dazed expressions. Lloyd shouted louder at them.

“Move away from the hole!” he bawled. “As far as you can! I’ll take away the bonus of anyone who disobeys!”

Right now, Lloyd had to resort to a method that brought about an instant reaction, not understanding. That was the fastest way to make them evacuate. Lloyd was right for thinking so. At the warning of bonus forfeiture, everyone hurried away from the hole as there was nothing scarier than that.

Pssssh! Thwack! As soon as they went away, one Mastodon carcass emitted a flash and violently exploded. The gas, fire, and explosion compounded to bring another Mastodon burst. Then the one next to it burst again. And one after another, each emitted a flash, leading to a chain of destructive explosions.

Boooom! 50 Mastodon carcasses exploded in a flash, but the explosion wasn’t ordinary and natural. It wasn’t the burst of gas from their guts. What just took place was the explosion of mana, wretchedly destructive enough to turn the area into a nightmare. Lloyd knew of this type of explosion because he had read *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

Dammit... I knew it... It’s corpse explosion magic.

The story popped up in his mind just then. A necromancer consistently processes the dead bodies and casts explosive magic. And when the set condition is met, they burst and explode with so much power to reduce the whole place to rubble. The power was tantamount to the size of the dead body. It was said that the size of a human corpse contains about the destructive force of an AT mine. But right now, things were worse than when they weren’t corpses.

Since a Mastodon is as big as an elephant, then... Argh!

Cursing under his breath, Lloyd jumped out of the hole to fix his grip on the shovel. Then he turned around and got ready to fire a triple mana blast into

the grave. It was too late to completely avoid the explosions and shockwaves. It was wiser for him to contain them using the triple mana blast.

I have to try even if it doesn't work.

He rotated three circles as his eyes beamed. But just then...

"Bibeong!"

Everything turned black for Lloyd after he heard a loud shout. It was Bibeong, who blocked Lloyd with his giant body, and he curled to hug Lloyd as though he was trying to protect him from the explosion.

"Bibeong!" called Lloyd.

"Bibeo-beong! (Get down!)"

Lloyd got down by reflex, and the explosion and shockwave swept over the area.

...!

Lloyd neither heard anything nor felt the flash. But the sky and land seemed to have turned upside down, and his stomach seemed to churn tumultuously. The painful ringing in his ears engulfed every sound around him. Lloyd opened his eyes, but he couldn't see anything. He wondered if the white thing was the sky. But what about the dark one?

Bibeong...?

Lloyd found Bibeong lying on the ground. To Lloyd's relief, Bibeong was alive, which was evidenced by his moving stomach. Lloyd then staggered to his feet, enduring the pang of dizziness and checking on Biebong. No blood or serious injury. But he looked like Bibeong fainted from the impact of bearing the full brunt of the explosion.

What about the others?

Drip. A streak of blood dripped along his forehead. Lloyd wiped it with his sleeve and looked around. The ringing noise in his ears calmed a little at last, and the sound gradually came back.

Cough! Cough!

“W-what just happened?!”

“Argh... A-are you all right?”

Lloyd saw the nearby workers getting back to their feet. Lloyd was relieved that no one died or was badly injured. It was because Lloyd had shouted prior to the explosion to get away from the hole pronto.

What... the heck?

Lloyd slapped his cheek hard, and that finally restored him somewhat from dizziness and nausea. Just then...

“Oaaak... Oak!”

The inside of the hole, where the explosion took place, let out a coarse, ferocious roar. But it wasn’t just one.

“Kwoak!”

“Kwa...oak!!!”

At least dozens more began to roar in series, their cry ringing aloud the area ominously. The noise neared as the storm of dust subsided. Lloyd grimaced.

Wait a second. Is this...

Right when Lloyd wondered if the carcass explosion was just the beginning, something happened.

Fwish!

Something large loomed amid the sandstorm.

“...!”

He immediately ducked down and stepped back to feel something long, as long as a log, slashed the space right above his head.

Elephant nose?

No, it belonged to a Mastodon. It could only mean one thing. When he was hit with such an epiphany, a large figure broke through the dust and charged ahead.

“Kwoaaak!”

“...!”

They were Mastodons, but they weren’t alive. Lloyd could tell that right away by the blank eyes, which he thought were like a dead fish’s, and the rotten skin all over their bodies. But in terms of their ferocity and hostility, they were more alive and real than the living ones. They then hurtled toward Lloyd, wielding their tusk and horn, entirely bent on smashing him to pieces. They were undead Mastodons.

Argh!!

These monsters looked like they should be starring in horror movies. So, the sight of these undead creatures hurtling toward him made his skin crawl.

Carcass explosion, and the undead?

It was clear. The necromancer who performed this dark magic was a considerable magician. Hundreds, not just one or two, but hundreds of undead Mastodons, excluding the ones that just exploded in the hole, stampeded toward Lloyd.

Dammit!

Every hair on his body stood. Lloyd wanted to run away. After all, he wasn’t the brave main character of an action movie. He never cared about risking his life and putting himself in harm’s way to be a hero.

So why is this happening to me?!

Lloyd berated his fate. He was just making a sludge treatment facility when out of the blue, this event took place. If Javier were here, he'd have tossed the mission to him being the brave fellow he was. It would have been a cinch for him. Just his usual amazing sword tricks and the undead Mastodons would be done for. But Javier wasn't here as he was cutting up the metal rebars with his aura at the apartment construction site. In other words, everyone's life depended on him. Otherwise, they would perish.

"Everyone, run!"

Lloyd bawled as loud as he could. Thankfully, his shouting was effective. The workers, who were frozen in surprise and fear, flinched. It appeared that they had finally read the situation. They were taken aback.

"A-aaack!!!!"

"Run!"

"Run for your lives!"

Most of the workers were residents and refugees. Some engineers were a little stronger than the rest, so none stood a chance against the undead Mastodons. Throwing their shovels and pickaxes in fear, they skedaddled southward where the fiefdom was. But unfortunately, their frantic steps provoked the undead.

"Kwoaaak!"

The leader in the group roared ferociously, and with its half-rotten, muscular nose, it pointed at the workers. The entire herd stampeded toward them.

"Gwoak!"

These undead Mastodons burned with hatred for life. They rushed as the ground shook underneath their feet, and their hostility signaled the

ferocious determination to trample everything in the way. But something did stand in their way. Six men. The members of the White Cavalry.

“We! We are the sword and shield to Her Majesty!”

“As the sword and shield of Her Majesty! We must protect the people!”

Lloyd wasn’t spared a second to stop them. They immediately charged with a shout after pulling out the sword toward the incoming herd of monsters. It didn’t matter that they were on foot and without armor. They charged. They were trampled.

“Gwoack!”

These Mastodons were stronger than the living ones after being perverted into the undead. Their spears and swords didn’t even leave a single scar on them.

“...!”

And those six members of the White Cavalry were tossed and thrown and trampled by the herd that they lost their lives. Lloyd gritted his teeth when he saw the sight.

I told them to run! What are they doing?!

They had just shoveled with him until earlier, but now they were dead. His hands shivered. No more lives could be lost like that. As such, Lloyd needed to come up with a plan. Anything. The pieces of information, the situation, the terrain, and the forces were processed individually in his head to devise a method that would keep everyone safe. Just then, an epiphany struck him, and he developed a feasible plan.

“Ppodong!”

Lloyd reached his hands into his inner pocket and brought Ppodong out.

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!”

Ppodong must have been reading the situation as well. He opened his mouth as soon as he was brought out, and Lloyd tossed a piece of red sunflower seed there. Then, he hurled Ppodong high.

Boom!

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong turned giant.

“Stall them first!” shouted Lloyd. “As much as possible!”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong nodded and bolted toward the head of the Mastodon that stood in the front.

“Ppo-do-dong!”

Crack! He rammed the undead monster with his body. Ppodong’s body was 32 feet tall, while Mastodon was only 13 feet tall. And he was heavier than the Mastodon many times. Even if the latter was a ferocious undead monster, the weight difference could not be overcome.

“Gwoack!”

The seven monsters in the front stumbled and fell to the ground like pins in a bowling alley. But the real problem came after that.

“Gwoak!”

Those behind them rushed like a tsunami. Lloyd ballparked the number to be at least 300. And Ppodong wasn’t strong enough to fight them all alone.

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!”

And so, he removed himself from the herd with a struggle, but not without any injury. The horns and husks poked his butt a few times, but he didn’t bleed. Nonetheless, the pain was unbearable. Ppodong wasn’t going to give

up, however. He rushed forward only to steer and turn back. Then, going faster, Ppodong rammed those in the front once again.

“Ppodong!”

Crash!

Five and six Mastodons flew in the air every time. That slowed their stampede. While this was happening, Lloyd ran toward the workers and found the civil engineers and the White Cavalry, who were lining up and getting ready to fight.

“Sir Bayern! Sir Blanc!”

The former led the civil engineer corps, while the latter led the White Cavalry.

“Master Lloyd, please evacuate now. We will protect this place,” Sir Bayern said.

“Leave this to us, the White Cavalry. I will prove to you that our valor is not groundless.”

The two men promised with determination on their faces. Lloyd shook their heads fast as he looked at them.

“No, I want you all to run away. You two. The corp and the cavalry. Everyone.”

“Excuse me?”

“I’m saying that I’ll buy time for you. So, hurry up and take the others and leave pronto. Right now. Got it?”

“Master Lloyd. I’m not sure what you mean...”

Sir Bayern’s face paled. On the other hand, Sir Blanc grew stoic.

“What do you mean?” Sir Blanc asked. “Are you saying that the Cavalry must turn our back when the enemy is there?”

“Yes, that’s exactly what I mean,” Lloyd immediately answered him.

“There’s no point to this fight. So, protect the workers and head down to the south. I’ll buy you all enough time.”

“But I cannot follow your request. You see, the White Cavalry-”

“This isn’t a request.”

Lloyd interrupted, and he stared at Sir Blanc, cold and void of any emotion. And to prevent any unnecessary sacrifice and save everyone, Lloyd spoke, his voice dripping with strictness and sternness.

“This is an order.”

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Chapter 152: Runaway (2)

“Hmm?”

Solitas, who was paying close attention to the work in the forge, stopped what he was doing. The wood sculpture and the graver left his hands, and Solitas gazed out at the north.

I just felt an explosion.

It wasn’t near here. It was yonder over the northern area of the fiefdom. A human couldn’t feel it because it was far, but he could since he was a dragon.

Is it just a simple explosion? No. I felt the mana.

He found himself already standing. Then, concentrating his senses on the north, he walked over in that direction, and the remnants of the mana could be felt more clearly the closer he got.

An explosion of mana. Magic. The pattern of the mana shaking. Necromancer’s bringing of the dead. Then, could it be the corpse explosion? But it was way more powerful than the usual ones.

The excellent dragon that he was, Solitas could almost get an accurate picture even though it happened miles away from his studio. And he was also aware of who was in the direction of the explosion.

Lloyd Frontera. Hmm. I wonder if he’s involved.

Solitas waffled over whether he should help out. But he couldn’t be bothered. Then again, he thought it was only right that he should go. As the internal debate took place in Solitas, there came an acid comment behind him.

“Well, well, look at you! During my time as an apprentice, I hyper-focused on my work and never did anything else, be it a cough, until I was done

with what my master assigned me to do.”

“...”

When Solitas turned, his gaze locked with Corgidus, his teacher, and the latter was stringently looking at him.

“Tell me, are you done with the carving I told you to do?” asked Corgidus.

“Um, no. Not yet.”

“Then, you should finish it.”

“...”

“Focus on the work I gave you. Start with the wood, and then we will move from plaster to granite to metal. Once you get used to them, I shall let you work on the pebbles that are the size of a nail, and only then will you learn how to deal with jewels. How long this will take all depends on you.”

“Hmm, I see.”

Solitas agreed with his teacher. After all, Corgidus was right. But there was one more reason why he easily got back to work.

Javier Asrahan. Does he have the same level of senses as mine?

Solitas’s gaze moved to the main road, and he saw the silver-haired knight dashing in that direction. It was Javier, and he was zooming northward.

I knew it.

Solitas figured that the knight, too, felt the explosion a moment ago. That must be the reason why he was sprinting northward. As such, Solitas was relieved.

He’s on another level. I felt it from our last fight too.

Once that man of monstrous caliber went to help, Solitas had nothing much to worry about. If there was anyone he should be worried about, it was himself.

Whew. Why is carving wood so difficult?

Solitas returned to the studio and picked up the block of wood again. It was ugly, with its edges all pointy and irregular. But Solitas had put a lot of effort into this. He sighed as he looked at his product. The future was undoubtedly bleak and hopeless at this rate. It would take eons until he worked the stones well and got ready for marriage.

But I'm not giving up. Dating, marriage, or revenge.

Javier Asrahan. Solitas vowed to himself that he would pay back the shame decades later. Resolving such, he picked up the graver again.

***

"Whew."

Lloyd picked up the shovel and gazed at the south. The workers were growing distant now, surrounded by the protective engineers and the White Cavalry. Just then, an event that happened a moment ago came to his mind.

Sir Blanc is one stubborn figure.

Lloyd said he would buy them some time so no one was to fight the undead Mastodons head-on. The rest must help out with the evacuation and run together. But the plan prompted violent opposition from Sir Blanc, who clamored that it could never be done as they were the swords and shields of Her Majesty. As such, the suggestion to turn back in the presence of the enemy was preposterous. The man voiced strong determination as he sternly looked at Lloyd. And so, Lloyd was left with no choice but to order.

"*This isn't a request. This is an order.*"

Lloyd put on a straight face and spoke strictly on purpose. He said that the authority to give an order belonged to him as the White Cavalry was

dispatched to the Frontera county under the orders of the Queen at the moment and thus rightfully subjugated to the orders of Count Frontera. And the person in charge of the construction supervision was him, that is, Lloyd, as the count had relegated his powers and authority to Lloyd. And what about the White Cavalry, which joined the construction project as workers?

“Obviously, you are within the boundaries of my responsibilities. Moreover, since an unexpected accident took place to risk many lives, the operation control to command the whole site belongs to me all the more. Plus, tell me, what is the point of this meaningless debate? Do you not think that it is right to take action as one amid this crisis instead of chitchatting?”

Lloyd spoke fast, emphasizing each word and never drawing his breath until he was done. Then, he stared Sir Blanc in the eyes. The trick must have worked. Sir Blanc finally nodded.

“It appears... that you have a plan in mind. Anyway, do be safe out there.”

After that, Sir Blanc joined the rest of the workers as he led the White Cavalry in the rear formation. Sir Bayern and the engineering corp were with them. And once they were gone, Lloyd was left alone in the wilderness of the undead Mastodons. Actually, Lloyd was with five baby Mastodons.

“Anyone not happy with the plan?” asked Lloyd.

“Chuuu!!”

“No complaints, right?”

“Chu!!”

The five baby Mastodons flared their noses in nervousness as they shook their 6.5-foot tall body. An apologetic smile faintly formed on Lloyd’s face.

“Yes, I’m sorry,” Lloyd said. “I’m not doing this because I want to do this, but I need your help on this one.”

“Chuuuu!!”

“All right. Okay. Okay. Don’t lick my face. You haven’t brushed your teeth.”

“Chu!!”

Lloyd soothed the baby Mastodons for a while. The sudden explosion and the following herd of undead Mastodons shook the babies to the hilt. It was reasonably chaotic and terrorizing. Nonetheless, they had to remain calm.

“So, I need you all to move with me calmly. Okay? That’s how you and I all can survive,” explained Lloyd.

“Chuuu!!”

“Okay, okay. Good kids. So, are you ready?”

“Chuuu!”

Rumble...

The ground was shaking now, and Lloyd turned toward the north to spot the herd of undead Mastodons charging in his direction about 200 yards away. He also saw Ppodong, who was running way ahead of them.

“Okay!” said Lloyd. “Ppodong, come here!”

“Ppodong!”

Lloyd hopped on Ppodong’s back when he arrived, all panting and breathing hard. His hair was a mess, as though he had a big scuffle with the Mastodons as he stalled them. Lloyd was hurt with a pang of gratitude and sorriness. He then lifted his head. The herd was now about 100 yards away. Now, things mattered from now on. It was the real deal. Lloyd had to do it right to propel the Mastodon herds to stop pursuing the workers and be on his heels instead. Come hell or high water. That was the only way to ensure the workers’ safety. Resolving such, Lloyd grabbed Ppodong’s nape.

“All right, let’s go! Off we go!”

“Ppodong!”

“Chuuu!!”

Ppodong leaped, and five baby Mastodons followed beside him.

“To the west!”

Lloyd sped, and he soon turned around to bawl at the undead Mastodons that were heading south.

“Look here!”

Lloyd held up his shovel and pointed at the baby Mastodons, who were running parallel to Lloyd.

“I got your babies in my hands!”

Lloyd’s shout grew louder.

“Unless you come to save them! What do you think I will do to them? I am going to kidnap them! And take them to the slaughterhouse! And! Their horns and tusks will be pulled out! I’ll also skin them alive and sell them for a good price!”

Lloyd wielded his shovel violently, and using the Asrahan Core Technique, he loaded the mana into his voice.

“Can you hear me?!”

Lloyd’s mana-charged yelling clanged aloud throughout the wilderness until it came within the earshot of the undead Mastodon herds heading south. Lloyd observed their movement with bated breath.

Please... Take a right. Please.

Just then, Lloyd recalled a part in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.*

Mastodons. They were giant herbivore monsters who lived in vast plains. It was said that they live in groups and collectively raise and bred their babies as one, much like the buffalos inhabiting the fields of the North American continent.

The book also said that they're obsessive when it comes to babies. It was so serious to the point that such motherly instincts still existed in part even after they became undead.

From the moment Lloyd was hit with the part in the story, he thought he could capitalize on their strong instinct, which was even more powerful than death. So, he devised a plan in a flash and evacuated everyone to a safe place. Lloyd figured that he could buy them enough time for them to run away.

"Okay, so! I have your babies! I'm going to kill them! I'll kidnap, hurt, beat, and sell them!"

Fwoosh! He wielded the shovel violently, and the baby Mastodons wailed after being terrified by the ferocious shovel.

"Chuuu!!"

Just then...

"Gwoak...?"

The Mastodon herd charging south slowed at once. They turned to Lloyd's side. And their blank eyes suddenly held a glint of a vague motherly emotion.

"Gwoak... Gwoak!"

Babies. The babies were there. Fledgling and young babies who still needed the protection and care of their mothers. They were crying there. When they realized the presence of the babies...

"Gwoahhh!"

Gallop! Thwack! The undead heart changed the direction to the west. They angrily made for Lloyd's side.

Awesome.

Lloyd clenched his fists. He succeeded in drawing their attention. Right now, the only job left was to safely run away and lose them.

"I already had the path in mind. Ppodong. Continue to head west!"

"Ppodong!"

Lloyd cut across the wilderness, and at times, when the distance with the undead neared, Lloyd fired mana blasts. When he did...

Thwack! Thump!

"Gwoak!"

The Mastodon on the lead got knocked out by the mana blast, which pierced from the head to the butt in a straight line. It flopped to the ground and burst.

Kaboom! Corpse explosion. The file was greatly disturbed, at least for a while, and Lloyd broke out in a cold sweat as he saw it.

Good that I didn't choose to fight them head-on. I made the right call by sending the White Cavalry away.

It appeared that the corpse explosion magic got activated automatically when they were neutralized. Had the White Cavalry proceeded and fought head-on, they would have suffered huge casualties by the explosion.

I made the right call. Good job, earlier Lloyd.

Lloyd continued to run and sped faster. Sometime later, at last, there appeared a steep cliff on the edge of the wilderness. Lloyd pointed at one area of the cliff with his shovel.

“Hey, Ppodong. Over there! See that?”

“Ppo-do-dong?”

“The valley on the side of the cliff!”

There was an entrance to a narrow valley where Lloyd was pointing at. The valley was so narrow that it was as though someone wielded the ax to split the cliff in half.

“Enter there! We’re going to pass straight through the valley!” yelled Lloyd.

“Ppodong!”

Past the valley, there was a forest of considerable size.

We can hide there. I can make Ppodong small again. Then, we can lose the undead very well.

Lloyd and Ppodong hopped into the valley as he thought about the plan again. But a few minutes later, he learned that a great hurdle lay ahead of him.

What the heck? Why is the valley torn down?

Lloyd had to stop Ppodong, and with disappointment and despair in his eyes, Lloyd gazed at the blocked wall that stood in front of him.

“Dammit...”

The valley had collapsed, and the path straight ahead was blocked entirely. Both sides of the cliffs crumbled, causing tens of thousands of tons of dirt and rocks to barricade their way.

Is it because of the spring rain?

It appeared so, indeed. Lloyd’s heart pounded violently.

Crap. If it’s like this, my plan’s a failure.

Behind him was the herd of undead Mastodons that wanted to kill him. And in front of him, the valley he thought was well-paved was blocked by the landslide. The path he had taken to get here was long and narrow, so there was no way to the other side. In other words, Lloyd was at an impasse.

Shoot.

Lloyd heavily broke out in a cold sweat, but he didn't allow himself to be gripped with panic. He didn't waste his time by fussing about this predicament, either. Instead, he immediately shouted aloud.

"Everyone! Get close to the cliff!"

This cliff wasn't suitable for climbing, and it was evidenced by his quick surveying skill.

It's sandstone. They break easily. Try to climb the cliff, and you're sure to free fall. Besides, the ground is still wet from the recent rain. If I'm out of luck, I'm going to cause a landslide.

And he would be buried alive. As such, the attempt to climb up the cliff and make it out alive was better put aside, especially when Lloyd was with Ppodog and baby Mastodons. Lloyd, having done the math in seconds, stared at Ppodong.

"Listen to me carefully now," Lloyd said quickly and straightforwardly. "I need you to hug the baby Mastodons. And stay right close to the cliff. Don't come near me until I tell you to do so. Okay?"

"Ppodong?"

"Got it?!" demanded Lloyd.

"Ppo...dong!"

"Good boy."

Ppodong was always a good boy. Being a good boy, Lloyd stroked him once before turning around. He then headed to the narrow path he had

taken, and in the distance, he noticed one undead Mastodon rushing along the curved path of the valley.

“Gwoack!”

Kaboom! There was a murderous look in their eyes. But Lloyd didn’t stop. Instead, he simply stepped forward to face them as he lifted up his shovel. He clashed three manas and fired the triple mana blast into the sky.

I can’t use the mana blast at them in this narrow place as the corpse explosion will cause a landslide. So... this is the best shot I have against them.

He used every bit of his energy to use the triple mana blast. The wretched exhaustion and dizziness following it forced Lloyd to collapse to the ground. And he scoffed as he looked at the violent herd coming his way. He was resolved. He closed his eyes and allowed himself to fall into a trance. At the same time, a clear alarm rang in his head.

Ding dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option ⑤: Supercharge has been activated.]

[You are absorbing a large amount of mana from random surroundings.]

From then on...

Ziiiiing!

The undead Mastodon herd was ready to pulverize the valley. Lloyd flopped in front of them with aplomb. And he, who became a mana blackhole, started to engulf everything that came his way.

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Chapter 153: Mana Predator (1)

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option ⑤: Supercharge has been activated.]

[You are absorbing a large amount of mana from random surroundings.]

Ziiing!

Lloyd's eyes closed, and he gradually lost consciousness. Something took place in his heart. Three strands of circles that wrapped the heart accelerated. At first, it was slow, soft, and calm. But later, it became fast, violent, and ferocious. They rotated at a limited speed, only to transcend and break it. No more hesitation. Indiscriminate object. At last, everything was regarded as an object to be absorbed.

Kaboom!

The three circles roared, going tyrannical as they wielded influence all around them. Everything that came within 44 feet transformed into a storm, and he started to absorb everything that came into the zone.

Crack! Crack!

The moisture in the ground dried up in an instant. The ants on the earth, a nameless beetle, the fireflies flying nearby, and the ticks in the dust entered the supercharge zone and lost their mana. Their skin dried up, and they lost blood. And they cracked, soon reducing to ashes. The undead Mastodons weren't an exception.

"Gwoack!"

The one in the lead let out a ferocious roar, and its eyes held a glint of deathly sensation as they shot daggers at Lloyd. But when it took one more step, its eyes changed.

“Gwoak...?”

Ziiing! Its head entered the zone first, and its eyes, which held more water compared to other parts of the head, shrunk first.

“Gwoak!”

Thwack! Its eyes dried after its mana was lost. It sank and broke, and at least its mouth and ears twitched.

Crunch! Crunch! The inside boiled and the mana was lost in an instant and dried up. The layer of cells that held up the rotten tissue was instantly torn.

“Gwack!”

The skin and muscles split to turn the horns and husks into ash. Its joints and marrows broke and smashed to pieces, and the seven-ton body collapsed. And a second later, one more final thing happened. It was the evil magic the necromancer cast when they made the undead. The carcasses began to explode.

Whoosh! Kaboom!

The staggering and shrinking undead Mastodon exploded. It took place just about 15 feet from where Lloyd was sitting. The ferocious blast and shockwave. There seemed to be nothing that could protect Lloyd from the flicking flames. But it wasn’t the case. Lloyd was safe because he even absorbed the explosive force of the explosion.

Ziiing! Lloyd’s mana circle roared ferociously, and it rotated ravenously as it revealed its evil greed. The supercharge skill trapped the flames that flew toward his way and the shockwave that was enough to rip his body. It didn’t matter that the explosion took place. Actually, the skill welcomed this magical explosion as it offered Lloyd more amplified mana.

Ziiing! Lloyd devoured the explosion in a flash, and messages appeared in front of his closed eyes.

Ding Dong!

[You are absorbing a large amount of mana through the Supercharge skill.]

[The amount of mana being absorbed is going over the manaheart limit.]

[Your manaheart is being expanded by force.]

[You have attained a skill experience point.]

Crack! Crunch!

The mana inherent in Mastodons, the energy imbued by the necromancer, and the explosive force of the corpse explosion all transformed into mana. And it was absorbed by Lloyd in a short period. Indeed, it overstrained his manaheart, but it only worked to help him grow.

[The manaheart skill has been upgraded.]

Ding Dong!

If Lloyd had his eyes open and could read, he'd have welcomed the arrival of these messages.

[Skill Name: Manaheart.]

[Stage: Low-Level Sword Expert Lv. 3]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 340%]

[Currently Owned Optional Skills: ① Shock Neutralizer / ② Complete Resistance to Poison ③ Frenzy]

[Required RP to level up: 400]

[Current RP: 2,870]

Cough!

His manaheart grew too fast. Lloyd's body tumbled from the great impact. But even while this was happening to Lloyd, the Mastodons kept coming at him.

"Gwoack!"

Since they were zombies, they were barely intelligent. Yet, even when the others were reduced to ashes and exploded, they rushed without any end or stop. One after another, they continued to come and shrink as Lloyd usurped their mana and eventually exploded. But even the burst of energy was absorbed before they could hurt Lloyd.

Cough! "Argh!"

Every time the large volume of mana entered Lloyd's system, his upper torso tumbled as though he was caught in a storm. This experience differed from the time when he absorbed the mana of Queen Magentano.

Argh! Ack...!

The queen's mana was extremely pure. It was refined, processed, and spotless. And so, it was quickly absorbed, although its extreme density required him to enlarge his manaheart. As long as he did so, he could take the queen's mana just fine. However, the situation right now was poles apart from that time.

"Eek!"

Cough! Lloyd coughed violently, and blood spluttered out of his mouth. He was coughing blood because the mana of the undead Mastodons was too thick, dirty, and rough.

"Argh...!"

The mana belonged to the dead and decomposed creatures, and it was foul and evil because it received the curse of an evil necromancer. This mana would be the dirtiest one in the world, and it obviously left serious damage to the body that took it.

Grit! Lloyd gritted his teeth even as he was in a trance. Pain gripped him so severely that his body shook like a leaf as he endured the pain. He nonetheless maintained the absorption, and the more he absorbed the evil and corrupt mana, his body parts indirectly experienced death.

Thump! His heartbeat became irregular. Ventricular fibrillation took place. His heart muscles twitched, and cardiac infarction stifled his heart. But then the muscle soon returned to normal. The same thing took place in his respiratory system.

“Ha... Cough!”

Asthma attack. His bronchial tube narrowed in seconds. Breathing became labor, and several red spots dotted his face. The alveoli in his lungs rot only to become normal soon. This strange phenomenon took place throughout his body. An ulcer appeared in his stomach. Gall bladder stones were produced in his gall to block the pipes. Biles surged to fill up the liver. Bilirubin in his gall accumulated in his system. Jaundice. His liver tissue was ripped apart. Fibrosis. Acute hepatocirris.

His muscles went numb. Proteins were destroyed. Osteoporosis and arthritis plagued his bones. His blood turned strange, and his lymph nodes refluxed. His nerve tissues snapped, and his cartilage disappeared due to wear. Just like that, Lloyd’s body became half-dead in real-time, only for his body to fight back and activate the manaheart to the maximum. The destroyed tissues were restored, and the anomalies in his body were made normal. Destruction and regeneration. Death and resurrection. The repetition of these processes allowed Lloyd to train his body.

“Argh... Eek!”

His whole body twitched and shook like a leaf. His breathing turned raspy as he endured the pain. Even when he was in a trance, the pain was overwhelmingly great. The discomfort could not be expressed in words. But that process alone became training for Lloyd. After all, that was what training was all about. The ultimate purpose of the training wasn’t empowerment or development or making progress. Its true purpose was facing the uncomfortable reality.

That was why even those who trained their minds and the ascetics that did penance accepted such a strenuous process with open arms. The discomfort in the body, mind, breathing, psychology, and memory. The objective was to discover the discomfort through daily training. And by facing, acknowledging, admitting, embracing, and internalizing such discomfort, you can move on to the next part of the journey, which is discovering another level of discomfort. That was the objective of proper training.

Empowerment. Progress. Improvement. They were nothing but byproducts obtained in the journey toward one's goal. In that sense, Lloyd was forced to enter true and real training, and it had nothing to do with his will. In his training, he was thrown into the unending chain of extreme and radical discomfort and made to overcome it.

"Ack... Ah..."

His raspy voice was close to a moan. But, instead, he embraced the pain more desperately. He would've never done it if he was sound in mind and even a bit conscious. But on top of his trance, something else allowed him to perform such transcendental patience. It was his optional skill.

Ding dong.

[Manaheart Skill Option ③: Frenzy has been activated.]

[You blindly focus on one goal after falling into a state of frenzy for 60 seconds.]

Just in time, the Frenzy skill was activated. From then on, Lloyd's countenance turned peaceful. He endured the pain and continued the Supercharge. The corrupt, thick, rotten undead mana was received as it was, and Lloyd turned it into his own. At the same time, his manaheart expanded to a greater degree.

Ding Dong!

[The manaheart skill has been upgraded.]

[Skill Name: Manaheart.]

[Stage: Low-level Sword Expert Lv. 4]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 360%]

[Currently Owned Optional Skills: ① Shock Neutralizer / ② Complete Resistance to Poison ③ Frenzy]

[Required RP to level up: 450]

[Current RP: 2,870]

His manaheart skill leveled up in a flash. But there was more. It was just the beginning of his relentless growth. Messages appeared in series before his closed eyes. The manaheart skill increased like a surging storm. From four to five. Five to six and seven. After going beyond eight and nine, it reached ten. And it went further up.

Ding Dong!

[Skill Class Level Up!]

[Skill Name: Manaheart.]

[Stage: Intermediate-Level Sword Expert Lv. 1]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 600%]

[Currently Owned Optional Skills: ① Shock Neutralizer / ② Complete Resistance to Poison ③ Frenzy]

[Required RP to level up: 800]

[Your Manaheart skill level has risen to the rank of <Low-Level Sword Expert>.]

[Your manaheart successfully processed the extremely corrupt energy during your frenzy. For this special experience, you've been awarded

new optional skills.]

[Skill Option 4: Un...]

Just then… A new message appeared and covered the skill description message.

Ding Dong!

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option ⑤: Your Supercharge time is up.]

Ziiing... The mana circle went quiet following the emergency message. The violent rotation slowed down, and the devouring mana absorption ended.

Whoosh. The wind blew. The 22-foot absorption zone was carpeted with a thick blanket of dust. But the wind blew it all away. This dust was the dozens of undead Mastodons left with nothing but bones after entering the zone. Once the dust wind blew, an ominous silhouette appeared.

“Gwoack!”

More than a hundred Mastodons were left due to the narrow valley. Only one could enter at a time. Five minutes were too short to absorb the entire herd.

“Gwoack!”

Those who didn’t die by the Supercharge skill roared with hostility. Then, they hurtled toward Lloyd, who was still on the floor.

“Gwoackk!!!!!”

Stomp! Stomp! Stomp! The ground shook. The 13-foot undead monsters galloped. Lloyd, on the other hand, was sitting composedly in his posture without any protection. He didn’t look like he was going to stand and run away. It looked like this until Lloyd slowly opened his eyes.

“Ppodong! Ppo-do-dong!”

Ppodong, who felt that things weren't going smoothly, moved. He remembered Lloyd's warning to never get near, but he couldn't help it. At this rate, Lloyd would be stomped to death, and he had to prevent that. So, he rushed ahead without thinking. But when he passed by Lloyd and tried to ram into the incoming Mastodons, Ppodong heard Lloyd speak. Had it not been for Lloyd's calling, Ppodong wouldn't have thought twice about flinging himself to more than a hundred Mastodons.

"Ppodong, stop."

"Ppo...?"

The voice was calm. Ppodong stopped. Lloyd's eyes were open, and they were staring at the undead Mastodons. But something strange took place.

"Gwoack?"

The charging undead Mastodon in the very front stopped dead in its tracks. Strange. It merely met his gaze, but it was as though it was struck with lightning or gripped with terrorizing fear.

"Kwoaaak!"

And when the front one stopped, the entire herd followed suit. Just then, a new message appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes.

[Manaheart Skill Option ④: Zombie Domination has been activated.]

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Chapter 154: Mana Predator (2)

“Gwoack?”

The undead Mastodon was hurtling straight ahead as it shook the ground under its feet. But the merciless stomping came to an immediate halt as if it was struck with a bolt of lightning or covered with ice water. Its body flinched visibly, and it was rooted to the floor.

“Gwoack...?”

The undead never got scared. On the contrary, they always gave off an air of fearsome hostility, even in the presence of the most potent foes. No fear or hesitation. That was their biggest advantage. But right then, the undead Mastodon was gripped with a vivid and clear sense of trepidation when it locked eyes with Lloyd, who was sitting right in front of it with a composed gaze.

Ding dong.

[Manaheart Skill Option ④: Zombie Domination has been activated.]

A new message popped in front of Lloyd. The meaningful messages took a portion of Lloyd's view, like a bundle of surprise gifts or a medal of honor given to those who overcame hardship.

[Your manaheart successfully processed the extremely corrupt energy during your frenzy. For this special experience, you have been awarded new optional skills.]

[Skill Option 4: Zombie Domination - You can now control an undead creature whose mana is smaller than yours for a limited period of time. The domination period is contingent on your and the undead’s mana. During the domination period, the undead creatures will faithfully obey your commands. However, the dominated creatures obey you only when they are facing you. If this condition is not satisfied, they will

immediately turn hostile and aggressive. There is no limit to the number of domination entities. You can only use this once per day.]

It's just what the message said.

Lloyd's mind flew back to the event a while ago. It must have been right after he used the Supercharge. His deafened ears picked up the noise around him. He opened his eyes and saw the undead Mastodon charging at him. He was about to jump to his feet and evade when he spotted a message that Zombie Domination had been activated. His eyes then met the undead Mastodon rushing in the front, and a pang of terror appeared in the latter's eyes. The monster looked like a friend who borrowed money from you and ghosted you for a whole week. In other words, the Mastodon was scared.

So, to get this straight, I now have a skill that can dominate the undead for a certain period because I'd absorbed a large volume of undead mana with my Supercharge skill.

That was what happened, and it was evidenced by the herd of Mastodons that stopped in its tracks.

Ha. Who would have thought I'd obtain this sweet optional skill? Not me.

It was a spur-of-the-moment decision when Lloyd decided to use the Supercharge. He just thought that it was the most efficient and best way to stop the herd in this narrow valley. But now, he had earned a sweet optional skill.

I even became a mid-level sword expert.

Lloyd could feel that his senses were entirely different from before. The vigor in his body couldn't be compared to the past. To analogize, he was like a scrawny teenager visiting the gym for the first time when he was a low-level sword expert, but now, he instantly evolved into a ripped gym rat who could lift heavy weights without breaking a sweat.

My goodness, this feels like coming across a 100-dollar bill in my coat I had hung in my closet the previous winter.

But Lloyd knew that he couldn’t simply bask in the happiness at the moment. His gaze then moved downward toward the message window, where it showed the time left for the optional skill.

[Number of dominated zombies: 108]

[Time left: 4m 58s... 4m 57s...]

The number of Mastodons left in this valley was 108, and he now had only about 4 minutes and 50 seconds until the domination was over.

I don’t have much time. My, if only there was more time, I could put the zombies, skeletons, and the other undead creatures to work without charge.

There had to be a way to actualize his wish, but not now. Not a second could be wasted. Facing the undead monsters, Lloyd rose and walked backward near Ppodong and the baby Mastodons.

“Everyone all right?” asked Lloyd.

“Ppodong!”

“Chuuu!!”

“Yes, yes, I am relieved. It was scary, right?”

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!”

“Oh, you weren’t? You were hugging the babies, so they won’t get scared?” said Lloyd.

“Ppodong!”

“What a good boy,” complimented Lloyd.

It looked like Ppodong was hugging the baby Mastodons tight while he was in a trance due to the Supercharge.

“So,” Lloyd said as his eyes continued to look at the Mastodons, “let’s get out of here. Ppodong, listen up.”

“Ppodong!”

“Chuuu!!”

“We’re going to step on their backs to jump over them and make for the exit of the valley. We have no time, so don’t ask questions.”

“Ppodong...!”

“Chu!!”

They seemed to read that the situation was far from favorable. So, they simply nodded without any questions.

“Ppodong, put me on your back,” hurriedly instructed Lloyd. “And as for you babies, grab your tails with your noses. Like you’re playing with trains. Interlock yourselves like a string of sausages. You don’t get it? Here, like this. Good. Good job. Make sure you hold each other tight and never let go until we’re out of here. Okay?”

“Chuuu!!”

Since the valley was jam-packed with the undead Mastodons, Lloyd needed more than five minutes to push each and clear the road. So Lloyd was left with the option to hop out of here on their backs before the spell was up.

“Let’s go then!” shouted Lloyd.

“Ppodong!”

“Chuuu!!”

Time left: 4 minutes and 26 seconds. As soon as Ppodong and the baby Mastodons leaped, Lloyd commanded the herd of undead Mastodons.

“On your knees!”

Crackle! His order was processed in their heads, and the reaction was immediate.

“Kwo...ack!”

The one in the very front lowered its front leg after a short hesitation and did the same with its hind leg. Stooping its huge body to the lowest level, it then lowered its head and stretched its thick nose forward. Its position looked like a stair good for climbing.

“Okay, as fast as you can!”

“Ppodong!”

“Chuuu!!”

They stepped on the head and back of the first one and got up. And the whole area came into view.

“Gwoack...!”

More than a hundred Mastodons were in a line, filling up the entire valley.

“Let’s gooo!”

Everyone moved in perfect order.

Sprint! They stepped on the back of the first mastodon and kicked the forehead of the second. The third one’s butt was used as a foothold. From that moment on...

“Gwoak!”

Each time they stepped and passed by them, the trampled Mastodon sprang to its feet as though it was never laid down in the first place and was never under Lloyd’s domination. Each rose up with hostility and pursued Ppodong and the baby Mastodons with a deathly aura. The reason behind their changed attitude was simple.

Just look at how they change their attitude because I'm not looking at them anymore.

The condition of the optional skill, which was locking his gaze with the undead, was not satisfied as Lloyd passed by them on Ppodong's back. But he could not turn around and look at them since that would make the silent ones in the front stand up and attack. In other words, there was only one thing Lloyd could do.

"Run! Run faster!"

"Ppodong!"

"Chuuu!!"

Ppodong darted off faster as he understood the situation. His chubby waist jerked up and down, and his fluffy buttocks wiggled. Ppodong sprinted and dashed against the wind with every fiber of his being that his tiny feet and hands became invisible by his sheer speed. He was followed by the five baby Mastodons, who jumped and leaped in the air.

"Chuuu!!"

The eldest one, who had locked Ppodong's tail with its nose, cried out in surprise. It tightened its grip around Ppodong's tail some more. The same went for the second, third, fourth, and youngest. Believing each other, they stiffened their noses and buttocks. As a result, no one was left behind.

"Good. We should keep going like this. Run faster, Ppodong!"

"Ppo-do-dong!"

Time left: 3 minutes and 25 seconds. Lloyd quickly counted the remaining number of the undead Mastodons lying flat on the ground.

There are about 50 left. We're in the middle of the herd now. Since we left when we were at 4 minutes and 26 seconds, it took us one minute and one second to cross halfway. We can pull this off. At this rate, we can get out of here without any problem.

Lloyd felt hopeful. Safe escape was near. Feeling more confident, he encouraged Ppodong to continue dashing.

“Good! You’re doing a great job, Ppodong! Just a little more!”

“Ppo-do-dong! Pant! Pant!”

“You kids behind us! Don’t let go of each other’s tails!”

“Chuuu!!”

Good. Things are going very well. We should get out of here just like this, said Lloyd to himself.

“Okay, let’s gooo!!”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong ran faster. The number of Mastodons in front of them started to decrease. From 20, it became 15. Eight, five, three, two. Finally, Ppodong jumped over the last one. *Leap!*

“We did it! Head to the valley exit!”

“Ppodong!”

“Chuuu!!”

Now, the undead Mastodons were freed from the skill. Lloyd could turn around now, but he wouldn’t be able to dominate the monsters. Why?

The skill said that I can only dominate once a day.

So, the only thing left for them was running their butts off. Before anything, they had to get out of the valley, and then, blast the cliffs flanking the valley with a mana blast. The landslide would then bury the undead Mastodons. Once the plan materialized in his head, Lloyd encouraged Ppodong to dash along the narrow path. He jumped over a creek and turned a few corners. From a distance, there appeared the valley exit. A faint ray of hope

appeared. Lloyd became more confident they would make it out of there alive and safe. He thought so. But soon, he learned that he was wrong.

“Gwoack!”

Fwoosh! A ferocious shout came along with a rush of air. Lloyd felt something flying behind him.

“Huh?” Lloyd ducked down by reflex in surprise, and right at that moment...

Boom! A large, dark lump, flying at a great speed, brushed past Lloyd’s head.

“A rock?”

It was almost 10 feet tall. It looked like one of the Mastodons catapulted the rock with its nose.

I’d have kicked the bucket if I got hit.

Lloyd was relieved, but he nonetheless broke out in a cold sweat. But the next moment, he learned that his relief had come too early. The rock that passed him flew straight in the air toward the towering cliff on the side.

Eh...?

It flew hard and crashed down without stopping. *Boom!* The rock smashed the cliff, and the whole cliff began to rumble.

Boooom! Since the valley and cliff were narrow, the banged rock created a blaring noise and echo. The entire cliff shook to Lloyd’s fear.

No way.

A sinister feeling suddenly grew in him, Lloyd lifted his head and activated his design skill. Then, he saw.

A crack is spreading throughout the cliff.

The crack was tiny, but Lloyd could visibly see it grow bigger over time. Chills ran down his spine.

“Ppodong!” Lloyd found himself yelling in a high-pitched tone. “Run faster! As fast as you can!”

At that moment...

Crash! Boom! He heard a tilting sound and something exploding and then being crushed flat. Several areas of the cliff began to crumble. It was happening. The landslide.

“Dammit!”

Slam! Crash! Rocks came down everywhere. Ppodong dashed ahead, avoiding each from hitting him. He jumped, rolled, retreated, and rushed to survive. But there were too many rocks.

No. I can’t see the way out.

Doom. Despair. The tips of Lloyd’s fingers grew cold. The exit was near, but every path that led there was falling apart. No, everything that came into Lloyd’s view broke into pieces. Thousands and tens of thousands of tons of earth and rocks slid down all areas. There was no way out. And the mana blast wasn’t enough.

Really? This is how I die?

Lloyd was dumbfounded by this situation. Laughter escaped. He looked up. He felt victimized. He regretted saying that he would take the matter into his own hands. He should have escaped with the workers instead of risking it all by himself. But it was too late to regret now. No matter where he looked, the sky was no longer above him. There was nothing but dirt and rocks surrounding him. And so, this was really the end for him.

“I’m sorry you all...” Lloyd spoke as he realized his time was up. But at that moment...

Whip!

“…!”

Something white came down somewhere and wrapped around his arms, legs, and body.

“Ppodong?”

“Chuuu?”

The same went for Ppodong and the five baby Mastodons. Before they could respond, they were twined in something that resembled a white net. It was...

“A spider web?”

Lloyd’s eyes widened. The next moment, a shout came above the sky as if to answer Lloyd’s self-talk.

“Ggoming!”

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Chapter 155: A Responsible Person (1)

“Ggoming!”

A shout, coming from the sky, rang aloud. At the same time, something white flew in his direction and wrapped around him in a flash like a net. *Fwick! Whip!*

“...!”

Lloyd flinched at the abrupt ensnaring and stared at the white net that wrapped his body.

A spider web?

It was white and sticky. But Lloyd wasn’t the only one bound by the web. Ppodong and the five baby Mastodons were swathed with the spider web, too, as though they were parcels. And there came a tug. *Stretch!*

“Eek...”

The spider web was pulled with great vigor, and they were tugged in its direction as a result.

“Ppodung...!”

“Chu...!”

Tug! Ppodong was already sprinting fast, so when the spider web around him tugged forward with great strength, the two forces compounded to propel the former to an explosive acceleration. As a result, his speed increased by two-fold, and he was saved from the giant rock by the skin of his teeth.

Boooom! The mere noise of the rock falling to the ground created a blaring din. Lloyd wondered what would have happened if he had been crushed by it.

Well, no point in wondering! I'd probably have been pressed into a pancake.

Lloyd stole a glance behind him as he panted. Chills ran down his spine. But he didn't have the luxury of time to relax as he heard a shout above.

"I'm going to pull harder. Hold tight."

"...!"

At the same time, Lloyd spotted a familiar outline of a figure over the valley.

"Ggoming!"

A large parrotbill glided in the air with his wings spread wide. A silver-haired knight was on his back. It was Ggoming and Javier.

"Haha, ha! Javier, how nice to see you up!"

Stretch! Once again, the spider web roughly pulled Ppodong, but this time, it wasn't doing so forward. It was pulling him up. His two feet left the ground, and the same went for the five baby Mastodons. That is, Ppodong and five baby Mastodons were lifted in the air, tightly and painfully wrapped around by the spider web.

"Ppu-pu-dung!"

"Chuu!"

Everyone flailed in dismay. Ggoming's wings fluttered faster, and everyone was lifted off the valley ground. They barely passed through the tons of dirt and rock that were cascading down. They flew higher and higher until they arrived at the top of a safe cliff. Around this time, Javier's voice came from Ggoming's back.

"Sir Ppodong? I'm going to cut the web. Brace yourself."

"Ppodung!" Ppodong answered gallantly. Javier's sword glinted above.

Thwack! The spider web, which had been impressively holding up until now, was cut. Ppodong and the Mastodons fell to the ground safely. But not Lloyd. The spider web that tied him around wasn't cut. Dangling in the air, Lloyd cocked his head to the side.

"Eh? What about me?"

"Master Lloyd, please come up," Javier said.

Lloyd wondered whether Javier's voice sounded colder than usual. Grimacing, Lloyd grabbed the spider web and pulled himself up until he finally got up on Ggoming's back.

"Woah."

Lloyd let out a sigh of relief at the realization that he was seriously close to death today. But he couldn't sit and relax. He didn't even have the time or luxury to get the sticky spider web off his body.

"Are you hurt anywhere?" asked Javier.

"..."

Javier, who was sitting on the front saddle on Ggoming, sounded unusually cold. Lloyd's hand that tore the spider webs off his body stopped. Then, Lloyd took the seat behind Javier.

"What if I am? Are you going to blow my wound?"

"I plan to cut it up, so it won't rot," said Javier.

"Ack..."

If Javier's attitude was weather, it'd be a heavy snowfall. That was how cold and icy his responses were.

"By the way," Lloyd replied as he glanced down at the landslide, "how did you find us?"

“I heard it.”

“What do you mean?”

“I heard the explosion,” answered Javier.

“Wait, the first carcass explosion?”

“That was probably it.”

Javier nodded and recalled the events that led up to this point. He was simply doing his work in the apartment complex construction site and chopping the metal rebars Bangul excreted when he heard an explosion in the far north. Javier sensed that something was sorely wrong. The explosion was, though faint, loaded with sinister and evil mana. So, he left the site and looked for Ggoming first. If he was right about the accident in the north where Lloyd was...

I’ll be too late if I run there.

He was fast, but not faster than Ggoming’s flying. So, he searched for the bird and explained the predicament, how he wanted the bird to get big and take him there. Thankfully, Ggoming carried a red sunflower seed, which Lloyd gave each creature for emergencies. And once he became large, Javier flew to the site. On his way to the north, he bumped into the evacuating workers and heard a summary of what happened from Sir Bayern, who was leading them. He also learned about Lloyd’s various actions. This made him mad. Very mad.

“Woah. So, that’s what happened. Thank you. If you didn’t come to save us, then, whew. The mere thought of it is just horrible,” said Lloyd.

“...”

Lloyd was catching his breath behind Javier, thanking the latter for coming at the right time. Such an expression of gratitude was very rare for Lloyd, so it was precisely why Javier hated Master Lloyd more today and drove his point home.

“So,” asked Javier, “are you happy?”

“Huh?”

“I’m asking whether you’re happy about being saved by me.”

“Hmm... By the way, did something happen to you?” asked Lloyd in confusion.

“Nothing happened,” said Javier.

“Then, why are you so moody?”

“Moody? I would never,” denied Javier.

“Yes, you are. You are moody. Aggressive too.”

“...”

“Did I upset you?”

“Yes,” Javier confirmed

“Wow. So blunt.”

“I am,” said Javier, “trying to hold it in but can’t.”

“How so?”

“Are you seriously asking me that?”

“Is it because of the sacrificed White Cavalry?” asked Lloyd.

“Not at all.”

Javier shook his head hard, thinking that this young master was seriously clueless about what he had done wrong.

“The six knights of the White Cavalry did their job. They fought to protect the people as the swords and shields of Her Majesty, and they died with honor,” explained Javier. “That is their duty and responsibility. So, I may respect and mourn their sacrifice, but it is not something to feel sorry for. The problem is elsewhere.”

“Elsewhere? Where is it?” asked Lloyd innocently.

“The problem is that you, Master Lloyd, had taken the same action, forgetting your place.”

“What?” gaped Lloyd.

He really doesn’t know, said Javier to himself. This young master was completely in the dark about how important he had become to this fiefdom.

“Master Lloyd, have you ever considered what would happen if you disappeared?” blurted Javier coldly.

“Um, yes, I have.”

“Then, you should know what I’m going to say next.”

“I do. There will be no one to finish or continue the things I started once I’m gone. So, the whole fiefdom will perish and fall apart. That’s what you want to say, right?” asked Lloyd.

“Exactly,” confirmed Javier with a sigh. “It wasn’t this much of an issue before. I simply considered you a precious member of the Frontera family, the eldest son, and the successor to the lord... Nothing more. So, I thought in the worst-case scenario where I had to choose between the lord and you, I would pick the lord without hesitation. But now...”

“I have become important?”

“Yes,” replied Javier. “But not because I’ve grown fond of you. It’s because you are more responsible for the fiefdom’s future than before.”

“You know, you don’t have to add the last part,” said Lloyd.

“But-”

“Anyway,” interrupted Lloyd, “is that why you are so upset and sulky?”

“I was never sulky.”

“Yes, you are. You are totally sulking. I could see you pouting from behind.”

“Master Lloyd, do you think I am joking right-”

“I am not kidding.”

“...”

Lloyd’s voice sounded calm. He looked down at the herd of Mastodons gradually perishing under the landslide and recalled the moment of great emergency a while ago.

“I fully get what you are saying,” Lloyd continued. “And I know you have good intentions. You’re telling me to run safely and don’t take things into my own hands when danger arises. Right?”

“Yes,” Javier confirmed

“But you’re upset because I always get winded up in this situation by risking myself, totally ignorant of my place. I’m right on this one, too, right?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, that’s right.”

“But what else can I do? I don’t think I can be more careful in the future.”

“Why is that?” asked Javier.

“There are people that trust and work for me.”

Javier wanted to refute and fight back. But he couldn’t come up with anything, so he stayed silent. Lloyd continued to speak amid his silence.

“Of course, I don’t want to be in danger, either. I’m scared. And I hate dying all the more. But you see, everyone has their own responsibilities,” said Lloyd.

Lloyd was being frank with Javier. It went without saying that he hated the idea of getting hurt or dying. But he knew that such sentiment went the same for everyone who worked for him.

“If it weren’t for me, they wouldn’t have dug up the ground in the northern wilderness. I mean, the workers today. Don’t you think so? This construction project began because of me, and I’m the one in charge.”

“But-”

“You know, do you know what being responsible means to me? I may be the biggest liar there is and trick those who trouble me, but I never do such to those who at least trust and follow me.”

Just then, his experiences in South Korea came to his mind. Construction fields were always dangerous. Careless mistakes and accidents happened everywhere. Although he was never in an accident due to sheer luck, he heard of an accident every time he watched the news. There were reports of a fire breaking out in welding sites, old tower cranes falling, and many other safety accidents outside of those events. The victims were always the workers.

But no one took responsibility. No one really came out to be liable. If there was, it was the field superintendents, and they would get some disciplinary actions from the construction companies. Then, there came meaningless and nominal apologies and words of comfort. Companies sought ways to reduce the already shamefully small amount of compensation they had to pay.

That was it. Then, similar accidents repeated. No one came to get rid of the root cause of the accidents. Why? Because it was expensive and laborious. Maintaining the status quo and compensating the victims' families was cheaper than putting up safety measures. So, companies deflected all their responsibilities citing financial reasons as the excuse. Lloyd loathed them for it.

“So, I do not want to turn a blind eye to my responsibility toward the construction site I took charge of.”

Lloyd spoke, meaning every word, saying he would always be like this. He would never let go of his responsibility for the workers. He would take responsibility even when fear, annoyance, and laziness pressured him.

“Even so,” Lloyd added, “I will try to play safe since I don’t want to die or get hurt, either. I will do so just for you.”

“For me?” Javier cocked his head as he sat in the front, wondering what in the world Lloyd could mean. The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose mischievously...

“The lullaby service.”

“Excuse me?” asked Javier.

“You better tell me honestly. You’re doing this because there’s no one to sing the lullaby once something bad happens to me, right? Aren’t you scared because of that?”

“That is just outrageous...”

“Eh, looks like I have driven my point home. You’re upset.”

“Not at all. That is simply absurd,” defied Javier.

“Really?”

“Yes,” Javier confirmed

“You sure?”

“Of course.”

“Then, why are your ears getting red?”

“It’s because of the cold wind,” said Javier.

“There. Your voice cracked just a little.”

“This is troubling. Could something have happened to your hearing earlier?” asked Javier.

“My, my. Are you going to deny it like that?”

“There is nothing to deny.”

Javier jerked his head to the side after uttering coldly. Just then, an unexpected yet welcomed message appeared in front of Lloyd’s eyes.

Ding dong.

[Javier Asrahan is deeply touched by your aspirations and sincerity.]

[He now respects you a little more after having discovered your new side today.]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has greatly increased.]

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Chapter 156: A Responsible Person (2)

[Javier Asrahan now respects you a little more after having discovered your new side today.]

[He was refreshingly shocked by your thoughts and aspirations.]

[He now perceives you differently.]

[Your likeability with Javier Asrahan has increased by 15 points.]

[Current RP with Javier Asrahan: +23]

[You have earned 270 RP by improving relationships with main characters.]

[Current RP: 3,140]

[The intimacy level with Javier Asrahan has increased one level from <Average Regard> to <Average Favor>.]

[You have earned 100 RP as a bonus for the upgrade.]

[Current RP: 3,240]

Dang.

Lloyd cast his eyes over the bright messages, and a smile naturally formed on his face. His eyes growing slightly more mischievous, he stared at Javier's chestnut-like head.

"You rascal. Are you happy?"

"I'm not sure what you mean..."

"I'm asking if the speech from this wise, old friend of yours was touching," teased Lloyd.

“Don’t get excited. Not even in the slightest. That will never ever happen,” defied Javier.

Lloyd wondered why Javier’s shaking of his head looked particularly more aggressive today.

“I could never be touched by your words. How can I be touched by a man who jumps to danger without knowing the importance and significance of his life to others? And besides, I am not your friend,” reminded Javier.

“Why? You’re five years younger than me.”

“I am young, and not to mention, lively.”

“Hey, give yourself five years, and you’re going to be as old as I am.”

“You’ll grow older as well then,” pointed Javier.

“Shoot...”

“Anyway,” continued Javier, “I do not intend to think of you as wiser or older just from physical age. So, you can do away with your pointless expectations early on.”

“Are you pushing me away?” asked Lloyd.

“Our relationship was always like this in the first place.”

Javier’s voice remained cold. Laughter escaped Lloyd because he saw something he couldn’t help but point out.

“You know. Your words really don’t match your behavior,” said Lloyd.

“I am not sure what you mean.”

“You are grabbing my sleeve.”

Javier turned around wordlessly and looked down.

“You’ve been doing this from before. From the moment you got me on Ggoming’s back.”

“...”

“Are you grabbing me because I might fall?” asked Lloyd.

“You got it all wrong,” denied Javier again.

“How so?”

“I wished to grab your collar because of what you did, but my hands just don’t reach that far.”

“Aha. So, that’s why you’re clutching my sleeve?”

Javier was silent again.

“Makes sense though,” Lloyd agreed, “after all, I am an important and respectable man.”

“...”

“My goodness. What a good boy you are, Javier,” teased Lloyd.

“Do you want me to shove you down the cliff?”

“Really? Do you mean it?”

“I think this height is enough to cleanly send you off in one try. Just enough to end your tenacious life.”

“I think you’re being sincere now,” pointed out Lloyd.

“Obviously.”

“...”

Even when Javier went on uttering viciously, he never let go of Lloyd's sleeve as though he was worried that Lloyd might fall off. The tight grip allowed Lloyd to take a closer look at the situation beneath. The valley under Ggoming's wings was being crushed. Hundreds and thousands of earth and rocks were pouring into the valley, and Lloyd noticed intermittent explosions amid the overwhelming catastrophe. They were the zombie Mastodons bursting under the crushing weight of the earth and rocks. Those explosions led to a chain of more landslides.

Not a single one will be able to make it out alive.

Complete annihilation and burial. Even after things calmed down, Lloyd circulated around the area a few more times to closely check lest any creature survived. Thankfully, Lloyd couldn't spot any Mastodons that made it out alive.

"I heard from the workers evacuating a moment ago," Javier said in the front. "The undead Mastodons came up from the ground?"

"Yeah."

Lloyd recalled the previous event. He was digging up the hole to make a sludge treatment facility when he came across a legion of Mastodon carcasses.

"But they weren't buried randomly. It was all lined up in order."

"Must be the doing of the necromancer that made them," presumed Javier.

"I would assume so." Lloyd nodded as he spoke. "Who could it be? Anyone in mind?"

"No, not at all."

Javier paused for a second before continuing.

"No one comes to my mind. On top of that, necromancers are hard to come across."

“Hmm,” wondered Lloyd, “could it be related to the one we took care of the last time?”

“Do you mean the warlock that kidnapped our soldiers in the eastern range?” asked Javier.

“Yeah,” said Lloyd. “When we were building the seokbinggo in the orc village. Do you remember him?”

“Yes, of course.” Javier nodded. “Indeed, it could be that it is the work of the necromancer related to him. But I presume it is too early to think so-”

“Yes, I know. We’re jumping the gun.”

“Yes, I think so too.”

Lloyd stared down at the destroyed valley, confused. He was absolutely in the dark. Who created the undead Mastodons and buried them near the fiefdom?

I don’t have a lead to conclude whether it was a random chance that we came across the monster or whether it was to actually hurt my fiefdom.

Lloyd couldn’t figure out the answer even as he recalled *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Hundreds of undead Mastodons were buried in the wilderness north of Frontera county. This was something that never happened in the novel. And obviously so. The monster domino effect never even occurred in Frontera county inside the novel. The Mastodons living in the plain beyond the eastern range never came down here in the story.

Ugh. But I can’t just ignore this problem.

However he looked at it, Lloyd now had a problem to solve. In the case the Mastodons were buried for some other use, Lloyd had destroyed the necromancer’s storage. The victim might ask for compensation or hold a grudge against Lloyd. But otherwise, if they were intentionally buried to harm the fiefdom, Lloyd would be in greater trouble. Either way, it was bad for his future.

“Tsk.”

But Lloyd had bigger fish to fry at the moment. The first one on the front burner was to clean up today’s mess. The sewer construction had to go on. Lloyd would search for a lead to this mysterious necromancer in the process. Right now, he had to focus on his priorities.

“Let’s go. Over there.”

Lloyd first decided to tend to Bibeong, who lost consciousness when he protected Lloyd from the initial explosion. Thinking so, Lloyd pointed at the east. Ggoming’s fluttering of wings became faster.

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To Lloyd’s relief, Bibeong was safe. It was thanks to his massive tenacity that came from his giant physique. He was A-Ok even if the explosion burst right at his face. All he had were a couple of burned hairs and some signs of concussion.

“So Bangul,” said Lloyd.

“Bangul?”

“I think it would be good if you nurse Bibeong,” said Lloyd.

“Ba-bangul!? Bangul?”

“Oh, are you saying that Hamang would be more suitable for nursing him? Sure, throwing a bucketful of water will wash Bibeong very well and help him regain consciousness.”

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

“Hmm, but I disagree.”

“Banguuul?”

“It’s because Bibeong isn’t hurt that badly in the first place.”

“Bangul?”

“I think it’d comfort him more if you stay beside him instead of throwing water to his face,” said Lloyd.

“Bba-bangul? Bangul? Bangul?”

“I mean it. Trust me. You have the ability to do so.”

“Banguuul?”

Bangul cocked her to the side and kept it that way. But she nonetheless tended to Bibeong, patting his head and keeping his side. Lloyd’s prediction turned out to be on point.

“Bibeong! Bibeo-beong! Bibeong!”

Once Bibeong regained consciousness, he went berserk at the sight of Bangul. He argued that he was perfectly fine and that the explosion meant nothing. His hair was singed, but putting on some saliva would make it better. The same went for the concussion. He had experienced it before as well. He said that he was on the ground lying flat for a long time because he was tired. After he jolted up, he plastered a shamelessly confident look on his face. Bangul then started to scold him.

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

Cut the crap, Bangul dismissed. A patient must lie on the bed and sleep. Otherwise, she was done nursing him. This prompted Bibeong to hurl his body back to the ground at lightning speed.

“Bibeo-beong!”

Before he knew it, Bibeong put on a wide grin. Lloyd realized that he didn’t have to worry about him anymore. Afterward, he moved busily and first took care of the remains of the deceased White Cavalry with care. Cleaning up the accident site took him a few days. From the hole the Mastodons were found to the destroyed valley, Lloyd and the others thoroughly organized the places and searched around in the hopes of coming across a clue that

might point to the necromancer. But even after a few days of searching, nothing solid came out.

“But do not be too anxious. You see, you have no idea how glad and grateful I am that you are safe.”

Click. At the dinner table that came after a long while, Lloyd stared at the plate the countess held out. And he spoke.

“This plate seems to be a bit different from what you told me a while ago,” said Lloyd.

“Different? How?” asked countess Frontera.

“You dragged me here on my way out, telling me to at least eat a light snack even if I’m busy.”

“Yes, I did,” she said.

“That means I thought I came here to have a quick snack.”

“Correct.”

“But how do you explain the mountain of food on my plate...?” asked Lloyd.

“Why, is it because you want some more?” asked the countess, worried.

“No, I am worried that my stomach might burst open.”

“Do not worry. You have more to eat.”

“...”

Shut up and eat. Your opinion doesn’t matter. Lloyd wished the countess would be forthright and tell him that to his face. With a look of despair, he looked at the plate. The plate itself was huge. It was about 20 inches in diameter. So technically speaking, it wasn’t a plate. It was a round tray loaded with all sorts of food there. Lloyd thought that this food plate should

belong to a person who came to a buffet for the first time in their life or to a mukbang streamer. Salad, sausage, egg, steak, marinated meat and bread, pasta and mashed potatoes, buttered goose and salmon, cream-filled corn, and fried chicken... The list continued, and there seemed to be enough food to circle the training hall five and a half times.

“Um, I don’t think I’ll be able to finish this...” muttered Lloyd.

“It is all right,” said the countess. “You can take as much time as you want.”

“Um, it’s going to take me over ten days.”

Lloyd was flustered. He had a lot of work to tackle, so he needed to clean up the construction before sunset and check tomorrow’s work area in advance. Though he was exhausted and wanted to lie on the bed and doze off, he had things to finish. But Countess Frontera, who was well aware of his hectic schedule, was especially adamant today.

“I get it. I get that you are busy and wish to head to the construction site fast,” she said.

“Then, I will eat this sausage and leave-”

“When will I get the chance to see you if I do not do this?”

“...”

“Though he does not voice it, your father is distraught these days. He says that you are overworking and trying to carry all the burden by yourself.”

Lloyd didn’t reply.

“That is why I want you to listen to me. At least for one day, eat up until your stomach is full and rest. Give a break to yourself and to those who follow you,” she said gently.

“...”

Her quiet words seemed to touch his heart. No, in actuality, the countess had approached him with open arms. And with a concerned voice, she cooed over and assured Lloyd, who thought that her comforting words were like a pat on his back.

“So sit now, my son.”

“Okay...”

Lloyd wanted to know why his mind suddenly flew back to the time when he was in middle school. He thought about his mother, who urged him to eat dinner before leaving the house to study. Lloyd had told her that he couldn’t because he was busy.

I told her that even when I wasn’t actually going to study.

In actuality, he was skipping his studies to head to the internet cafe with his friends. He ignored his mother and bolted out of the house to get on time. One day, he found a bill in his jacket pocket. It was a crumpled ten-dollar bill his mother stashed to make sure that her son didn’t go hungry.

“...”

Lloyd regretted not listening to his mother. Maybe it was because of his remorse that the countess overlapped with his biological mother. But why? Was it because their gazes were the same? Or was it just because he missed those times? Crinkling his nose, Lloyd sat at the table and slowly chewed the food on his plate. Quietly, he kept eating.

He did so as he thought about his mother’s food he’d refused to eat in the distant past. One after another, he ate as though he was asking his mother for forgiveness. But no tears streaked down, or he didn’t even choke up. But it was very strange. For some reason, the food in his mouth tasted slightly saltier than usual.

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Chapter 157: A Responsible Person (3)

Two days passed, and during those past two days, Lloyd halted all his operations after taking Countess Frontera's advice for periodic breaks. Thanks to that, everyone sweating heavily in the field relaxed to their hearts' content and appeased their spirits troubled by the recent accident.

"Since we have rested up, we will be resuming the operation starting today," said Lloyd.

"Are you sure it is fine?" asked the count.

"Well, yes," replied Lloyd at Count Frontera, who was having breakfast. "The past two days gave everyone enough time to rest."

"Except you," said the count with a worried look on his face.

"I am always like this."

Lloyd smiled brightly and picked up some salad with his fork. The past two days were a break for the workers, indeed. But it wasn't for him.

"After all, people died."

The undead Mastodons ruckus killed six knights of the White Cavalry who gave their lives away to ensure everyone else could evacuate. They bravely formed a defense line against hundreds of monsters and sacrificed their lives. As such, Lloyd held a formal funeral ceremony for those brave souls, but he didn't bury them here. He instead collected their tattered remains, cremated them with care, and contained them in silver-studded jars. Afterward, Lloyd gave 30 knights of the White Cavalry a special leave and had them transfer the jars to the capital, along with a sincere letter of comfort and compensation.

The letter said that your beloved deceased was a man of valor who chose honor and gave his life to save others. It seemed like a platitude thing to say, but nothing else came to Lloyd's mind for the bereaving families. And

besides, Lloyd was feeling those words in his heart. He came to revere the deceased. So, he went further and sent another letter, this time to the queen, detailing their accomplishments and courage in their last moments and the honorable death they chose. Lloyd wrote as flowery as he could, thinking his eloquence would prompt the queen to take more care of the widows and children. Afterward, he visited Corgidus's studio and requested the dwarf to build a memorial stone that engraved the six knights. He did the best he could for them. Why? The reason was simple.

They are worthy of this kind of treatment, after all.

They had sacrificed their lives to protect the people of this fiefdom, so it was only obvious that Lloyd should be grateful to them. And his gratitude brought about a visit from an unexpected figure.

Sir Blanc visited me last night.

Just then, he recalled what had happened the previous night. It was around the time Lloyd came back after putting Javier to sleep. He found Sir Blanc hovering around the manor courtyard, and upon coming up to him, Sir Blanc said that he had been waiting for Lloyd.

"Thank you."

He first thanked Lloyd.

"You see, death is common for us. And as we stomp through the battlefields and wars, death is our friend, a daily occurrence. Maybe that is why I became slightly insensitive to losing my men."

Sir Blanc, standing beneath the faint light of the crescent moon, had watery eyes.

"So I was very surprised. I had never expected your family to formally bid farewell to my knights. So, thank you. They will be joyful that their death wasn't for nothing."

"Oh, I simply did what I had to-"

“Nobody has done this until this moment.”

Lloyd was silent.

“It was the same for the royalty. Of course, we are loyal to them. But not even once did the royal family ever mention the subject of proper burial and compensation for the deceased soldiers. So, at times, I could not erase the feeling that we are a formality, a small but special commodity and nothing else.”

Sir Blanc continued to speak.

“Therefore, I thank you. Thank you for not taking my men’s death for granted. Thank you for respecting our honor.”

At that moment... a new message appeared.

[Sir Blanc has opened up to you.]

[Sir Valeradi Blanc, the commander of the White Cavalry, is deeply touched by your noble character.]

[He has decided to sincerely follow you as an honorable knight while being loyal to the royal family.]

[He secretly wishes to be bound to your command.]

[From now on, you can increase likeability and earn RP from him.]

[50 RP has been rewarded for forming a new connection with another human.]

[Current RP: 3,290]

[Your likeability with Valeradi Blanc has increased by 5 points.]

[Current RP with Valeradi Blanc: +52]

[You have earned 45 RP by improving your relationship with a character.]

[Current RP: 3,335]

Dang.

Lloyd sucked in his breath. What he received from Sir Blanc was an indirect and secret pledge of allegiance. He felt guilty and happy at the same time.

It'll be problematic if the queen finds out about this.

Sir Blanc worked for the royal family, yes, but here he was, promising allegiance to someone else. Lloyd quickly smiled and encouraged the knight commander.

"I understand you, Sir Blanc. It is truly unfortunate and sad that you lost your men. I am sure Her Majesty feels the same way as I do."

Lloyd had mentioned Her Majesty on purpose, and it was only then that Sir Blanc looked like he had made a mistake. But his facial expression was removed after a second, and he bowed without a word and left. Lloyd was recollecting the event of the previous night when he heard someone call him.

"Master Lloyd... I have something to show you."

"Huh?"

A voice interrupted Lloyd's trance. He turned to the sound.

"Sir Bayern?"

Sir Bayern was in the dining room.

"What brings you here in the morning, Sir Bayern?" asked the count.

"As I said a while ago, I came to show you something. It's this."

Sir Bayern spoke and placed something on the table. It was a freshly cut head of a goat. But something was stuck in its forehead. It was a half-burned and ripped embroidery of the symbol of surrender.

“I have been conducting a search around the premises during the two days of rest, Your Excellency and young master,” said Sir Bayern. “It was done autonomously along with some men from the White Cavalry. And we found this late last night.”

“Late last night?” asked the count.

Sir Bayern nodded.

“Yes, Your Excellency. A member of the White Cavalry found it buried near the hole where we came across the undead Mastodons. We thought of reporting to you immediately, but we came here early in the morning since it was too late at night.”

“Hmm.”

The count observed the embroidery symbol and said, “A grim reaper with the head and wings of a black dragon. How strange. I have never seen it before.”

“Yes, Your Excellency,” agreed Sir Bayern. “I have never seen it before, either. But judging from the buried area and the goat head, I can guess that this is a talisman symbolic of the undead preservation magic circle.”

“It probably is. After all, a magical device would have been necessary to preserve the legion of undead Mastodons underneath.”

The count and Sir Bayern held a rich discussion about the symbol. It was their first time seeing such a symbol, so they put their heads together about its origin and the rumors surrounding it. As for Lloyd, he lost all appetite at the sight of it. But it wasn’t because he saw the goat head during breakfast. Sure, it was a grotesque thing to behold, but he had a strong stomach. There was another reason why he lost it. That symbol of a grim reaper with a black dragon’s head and wings was familiar to his eyes.

That... appears in the novel.

He remembered it, but where? In the novel, particularly in the new flag the queen adapted. It was the symbol of the flag that fluttered at the top of the royal palace.

Queen Magentano chose it as the new symbol of royalty after she lost one arm and turned into a tyrant. That is after she takes up advice from one of her people. That must have been when her tyranny and terrorizing reign began.

It was the beginning of the dark age. So, this dragon head grim reaper symbol was synonymous with tyranny and the dark age.

But what's it doing here?

Lloyd swallowed absentmindedly, and for a second, a scary thought crossed his mind. He wondered if Queen Magentano was behind the recent incident. He immediately shook his head.

No, it's not that.

There was no way. What would she get by harming his fiefdom? It didn't seem right. There was absolutely nothing she could gain from it.

I think it'd be more sensical to think that the one who proposed the symbol to the tyrant queen in the novel has something to do with this event.

The chances of that were more likely. The queen in this world didn't lose an arm or turn into a draconian ruler. Even if Lloyd rushed to the palace and showed the symbol to her right now, she would only tilt her head and think how funny the symbol looked.

So, it looks more likely that the person in the novel is involved in this... Hm... That's a pickle.

Lloyd frowned because he couldn't put his finger on who this figure was in the novel. The reason was simple. The novel didn't directly mention the person.

Not even a name appeared in the story. The figure was indirectly mentioned in her thoughts or monologues and nowhere else.

Lloyd wondered how they appeared in the story. It seemed likely that the person came up in sentences like, “Queen Magentano recalled the counsel of an advisor she recently hired” or “She looked back to the meeting with the advisor she recently hired.” That was why the online forum on the novel had some readers posting their guesses there. They theorized that this mysterious advisor was a disloyal subject trying to leech off the queen or that the figure was just a nobody. Some postulated that the figure was the true dark secret. But no one got the answer.

The advisor was never revealed, even after part one of the book. And the sequel never got published.

So, that was why this advisor was veiled in secret, only to be surrounded by so many speculations and assumptions. Lloyd was bitter that it had to be this way.

This is the reason why some authors are not good. They don’t have any sense of responsibility, not even a bit.

Lloyd internally cursed the author of the novel, how the author was irresponsible for not finishing the story and foul-tempered for leaving the readers hanging.

But still, it’s great that I know at least this much.

The difference between knowing an enemy and being entirely clueless was the same as the difference between the sky and the land. The knowledge of the enemy, regardless of how vague it was, allowed Lloyd to at least come up with some sort of preparation. He could even think of ways to attain more information in the future. At the very least, it pushed him in the right direction.

The reason Sir Bayern and the others searched the site for several days was to find a hint that will push us in the right direction.

So, for the time being, Lloyd had to rack his brain to find who the culprit was. He was planning to gather clues and have his ear to the ground about what was happening in the palace while doing his other work. Having decided what he needed to do, Lloyd spoke.

“Hmm... Sir Bayern,” Lloyd called.

“Yes?”

“I hope you did not bring this goat head for breakfast.”

“I did not, young master,” said Sir Bayern.

“Then, please remove it from the table,” said Lloyd.

“Oh...” he gaped.

The goat head boasted an amazing sense of presence with its tongue pulled out on the breakfast table. That was only when Sir Bayern realized what he had done. A flustered look appeared on his face. At that moment, a maid entered the room carrying a tray of cookies. She screamed her heart out when she saw the beast's head, her yelling ringing aloud the whole manor.

“Ackk!!!!!!”

***

Once that commotion was over, the construction for the sewer resumed.

“Bibeong! Bibeo-beong!”

Bibeong, who recovered after being injured in the explosion, passionately dug the ground. The area for the sludge treatment grew wider. The soldiers, knights of the White Cavalry, and refugee workers alike grabbed their shovels and worked like a dog as though they had never experienced the accident. After one, two, four, and eight days passed, their hard work and sweat actualized in the sludge treatment facility. Lloyd chose to use the gravity thickening method for this sludge treatment facility.

Simply put, it uses the force of gravity to concentrate the sludge to the bottom. It's much like the pit toilet used in provinces a long time ago. So, the structure is simple. I can also store and reduce sludge at the same time. It doesn't use any chemicals and is easy to maintain.

Actually, there was another sludge treatment model, but it wasn't suitable as this world lacked the right technology and equipment for it. He didn't have any choice, to begin with. Thus, he opted for the sludge thickener type, which was suitable for this place. The sewage and waste would gather in one place through the main sewer and flow into the sludge thickener. Once they were in, the sludge would sink to the bottom, and the remaining liquid and buoy would flow out of the letdown line. And he made a giant wooden lid on the upper side of the sludge treatment facility for Solitas, who was expected to take care of everything inside.

That way, we will be able to treat sludge with magic. Open the lid, and take the sludge out.

Lloyd actually wanted to opt for a more sophisticated method. But he couldn't do it. There was just no way to operate and manage the sludge hopper or sludge discharge pipe like in the modern era.

So, I should just do what I can.

He went on with the construction, doing what he could. Then, one day, in the middle of the hot summer, something other than the sweltering heat arrived. Letters. Marriage proposal letters from 59 noble families across the kingdom barraged the Frontera family.

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Chapter 158: Sweetness in the Air (1)

“Excuse me, Young Master.”

Lloyd was exceedingly worn out tonight. With the equipment belt around him, Lloyd had sweated buckets on the site as he supervised the construction under the searing sun. He wanted to wash up and jumped into bed. But against his wishes, he was met with a maid as soon as he set foot in the manor.

“Master Lloyd, the count instructed me to bring you to the office once you get home,” she said.

“He wants me in the office?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, Young Master,” she said with a smile. “The count appeared happy. It looked like he had good news.”

“Did he?”

“Yes, Young Master.”

Lloyd wondered what the occasion was. He shrugged.

Did he win a lottery or something? Obviously, that can’t be. Good news from the palace, perhaps?

Could it be, Lloyd mused, that the queen announced she would provide additional aid? Or did she decide to pave a direct road to the palace from the fiefdom? Lloyd wished that such a good thing had taken place. Thinking so, Lloyd followed her until they arrived at the office. She knocked on the doors, and the count meekly spoke from the inside.

“Let him in.”

His voice sounded slightly brighter than usual. Something good did take place, for sure. Lloyd’s heart started to thump in anticipation.

“Thank you for escorting me, Emily.”

It appeared that she never expected Lloyd to know her name. She blushed red and left the office. Lloyd turned and saw the count and countess sitting on the reception sofa.

“Welcome back. Tough day?”

“A little.”

Lloyd sat across from them, and the countess poured some tea on his teacup.

“I am sure it was more than a little hard,” the countess said. “It must have been tiring to work outside all day in this heat. You must be thirsty. Drink this first.”

Trickle. Lloyd took the chilled teacup, and as he wet his throat, he observed them both.

“Anyway,” Lloyd said, “why did you call me? Did something good happen?”

Both of them were all smiles. The corners of the count’s lips were literally hanging up to his ears so plainly. And the countess, though she maintained an elegant smile on her face, couldn’t mask the satisfaction that was written all over his face.

It looks like there really is something.

Lloyd searched his memory. These two nobles weren’t rash people. They knew how to express their joy or grief in an elegant manner. And so, he had never seen the count and countess be this joyful in the past two years. The only time this similar emotion appeared on their faces was when they paid off their crippling debt.

So, this means that the news is as big as debt clearance.

What could it be? As curiosity grew in Lloyd, the count spoke up first.

“Oh, my, look at me. I called you here but did not explain why. Here. Take this first,” said the count as he placed a thick bundle of envelopes on the table. It looked like it easily contained at least 50 letters.

“What is this?” asked Lloyd.

“See for yourself.”

“...”

More than 50 pages worth of letters? But the sizes and colors of the envelopes were at variance. The commonality was that the envelopes were all flashy.

What is this seriously?

Judging from the quality of the envelopes, the letters inside seemed to have come from an expensive place. Lloyd scratched his head as he picked up the one on the top. He carefully tore the sealing wax, and inside was a letter with a flashy insignia. Considering the soft texture of the paper, it looked like it was of good quality. He opened it up and started to wade through the letter.

Dear Count Frontera, I pray for your perpetual glory. In recent days, I cannot help but feel that your family’s reputation and honor are on the rise. It was then that I came across the news that your eldest son is not wedded yet. Fate has it that my second daughter has no suitable partner yet, so it is my wish to have a serious discussion with you, Count Frontera. Once again, I pray for your perpetual prosperity and success. I look forward to receiving a favorable response and hope we are lucky and blessed enough for an opportunity to deepen the relationship between our two families. Sent from the south. Count Cordona.

“...”

Lloyd blinked several times. He wondered if something had gotten in his eyes during work or if he suddenly couldn’t read.

Not wedded yet? Second daughter?

In short, it was a marriage proposal. It was a suggestion to form a strategic partnership between their families through the means of marriage.

“How do you like it?” the count asked.

Leaning very forward in his chair, Count Frontera gazed at Lloyd with glimmering eyes that reflected so much anticipation. And he looked so joyful. Putting on an ambiguous smile on his face, Lloyd spoke.

“Um, do the rest of these letters address the same topic?”

“See for yourself,” confessed the count.

“...”

“Since these are the official request for marriage between nobility, the letters were gathered at the House of Peers before being sent here. And actually, I organized them a little for myself,” the count said.

“What do you mean?”

“I arranged them in the order of family history and reputation.”

“From the top to bottom?”

“That is exactly what I did.”

“...”

“So, it will be easier for you to deliberate and make a decision. Um, do you think I am overdoing it, my son?” asked the count.

“N-no, it’s not that. It’s not that, but…” muttered Lloyd.

“But what?”

Lloyd couldn’t tell the count that this situation was a little burdensome.

Ha...

It was honestly startling. Making sure that he didn’t show the tumultuous emotions on his face, he scanned through the rest of the letters. Count Perano from the north, Count Esperia from the west, wealthy Viscount Sicily in the southwest, and so many others... Viscounts, barons, and other small nobles were mixed in the bundle. Actually, it wasn’t an overstatement to say that Lloyd received a marriage proposal from almost all nobles across the kingdom.

What’s happening?

Lloyd had never been this popular before in his life. 59 families asking for his hand? Total the number of times he flirted and had a crush, heck, add even the Korean singers he liked. The number wouldn’t reach 59.

“So, any family you are attracted to?” asked the count.

“...”

The count, who looked more pleased than before, asked. Lloyd emptied his cup before giving him the answer. Don’t get carried away, he told himself. When Lloyd drank the cold tea water, his troubled spirit found peace. Calmness returned, and his thoughts cleared. The reason for the arrival of a flurry of letters crossed his mind first.

There’s only one explanation. My family is rising in popularity.

But his family wasn’t just entering the limelight. It was one of the few fiefdoms that survived the monster domino that swept the whole area in the east. Thanks to that, his fiefdom had become the hub of the eastern reconstruction. The queen then announced relief plans and promoted his fiefdom to become a county. Not only that, Lloyd had the great accomplishment of saving the queen from an assassination attempt. In other words, Frontera county received unreserved, generous support and favor from Queen Magentano.

This means that my family will now be the strongest family in the kingdom for the next 20 or 30 years. We are a rising star. A stock set to soar to the moon. That's why everyone sent marriage proposal letters to tie the knot before we go higher.

Lloyd now had a clear understanding of what was happening. Once he knew, he also realized how he should act.

"Please forgive me for saying this in your joy, but I think we should turn every offer down," stated Lloyd.

"Eh...?"

The happy countenance cracked. The count froze. Lloyd spoke.

"I do not think it is time to get married," said Lloyd.

"How so? Why?"

The count's eyes held a glint of dismay and disappointment. Lloyd understood such emotion very well. As a father, Count Frontera must have been extremely joyful for his son to receive marriage proposals from such powerful families. But Lloyd was telling him that he had to turn everything down. Making sure that the count would not be hurt, Lloyd continued.

"To explain some more, I do not think it is very timely. I must concentrate on the reconstruction right now, and there will be hardly any benefits to getting married at the moment," Lloyd explained.

"Hardly benefit us? What do you mean, Lloyd? Are you saying, even if you got married, the possible material assistance would hardly matter?" asked the count.

"Yes, my lord," Lloyd defended. "The palace is sufficiently providing us with materials, and it's not going to be entirely free to receive things from the other family. Moreover, there is another reason it's too early for me to get married."

"Could you explain it to me?" asked the count.

He fixed his posture. Lloyd began to speak carefully.

“Answering their marriage proposals at the moment is the same as getting manipulated.”

“Manipulated...?”

“I suppose you can already guess why the nobles want to form ties with us through marriage. It is because we are currently being favored by Her Majesty.”

“Of course,” said the count.

“That is the exact reason. Our family has not reached its peak yet. We have more peaks to climb. Our value will only increase, so we should wait for a little longer. Our value will be proportional to the time we spend waiting.”

The Frontera county was like the land in Gangnam city before its development plans were announced. Or it was like a company waiting to dominate the market with its mobile phone. The heyday of the Frontera family hasn’t come yet. They had only started their ascent, and taking up a mildly appealing offer now would bring regret to the entire family in the end.

“As such, I believe it’s too early for marriage. Please wait a few more years. By that time, a family with greater reputation and status will send us a marriage proposal.”

“Hmm, what you are saying is that we do not have to precipitously form relationships with other nobles early on,” summarized the count.

“Yes, that is what I mean,” said Lloyd, “for time is on our side.”

“But I do not think time is on your side,” refuted the count.

“Excuse me? What could you mean, my lord?”

“You are a bachelor.”

“Argh...”

The count’s words were like a punch to his stomach. His words pierced into Lloyd’s ears.

“Think about how old you are. You are already 27. What kind of eldest son of a noble family stays single for that long?”

“Um, but...”

“Do you not think the time has come for your old man to have grandchildren?”

“...”

Here we go, Lloyd said to himself. The grandchild attack. Sure, the count made sense. He was 27 years old. In Korean society, he was still young and youthful, but in the standard of the Lorasian continent, he was clearly an old bachelor.

Still, I have to put my foot down.

Lloyd collected his thoughts. To be honest, he wasn’t interested in an arranged marriage with a noble lady when he knew nothing about her character, hobby, and face. He simply wanted to fall in love with an ordinary girl and get married like an ordinary couple. So, the time wasn’t ripe yet. Marriage could come when he met someone he really liked. Only then would he express his desire to get married to the count. Lloyd shared these thoughts with the count, emphasizing again that it was too early to get married. After all, all these families cared about was the things they would benefit from the marriage. They would turn around and abandon us if we staggered and went down, he said. Reasoning such, Lloyd calmly persuaded the count.

The count didn’t interrupt Lloyd. He simply listened, never being able to get rid of this sorriness in his heart. But the one who put an end to this battle of stubbornness was the countess.

“My dear, let us do what he wishes this time,” the countess said.

“Honey...?” asked the count in disbelief.

“Lloyd is the one who will get married, and he doesn’t want it. It is not likely that we will get married on his behalf.”

“...”

“Lloyd has always been a reliable child. So, let us trust him this time as well.”

“Whew.”

The count finally said “uncle.” With a dismayed look, he told Lloyd, “Is that what you really want?”

“Please forgive me,” said Lloyd as he looked down.

“Ha, I see. What do you want me to do then?”

“Simple. Please send a letter of denial,” Lloyd said firmly.

In moments like these, Lloyd had to be firm. He felt apologetic to the count, but there was nothing he could do.

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“Ha. I really suppose there is no other way.”

That night, past midnight, Count Frontera was still in the office. He restlessly paced around the office, unable to take a seat. Sighing at length, he couldn’t help but feel unsettled over what happened at dinner earlier.

That boy, I wonder if he has any plans to get married.

The count was concerned. A long time ago, he was worried about his son causing all sorts of nasty troubles, but now, he was anxious that his son was too virtuous.

Sure, it's nice that he is putting in the effort for the construction and working so hard. But I wish that he would get married soon.

Time was passing, and Lloyd was still a bachelor. There was no parent in the world who wouldn't feel anxious in this situation. On top of that, more than 59 families had sent them a proposal letter. But he had to turn every single one down. His heart sank as much as his heart had elated after receiving the bundle of letters.

But... I must respect his wish, seeing how adamant he was about it.

That was the respectful choice he could make. So, he had to do what Lloyd wanted. Taking a seat at the desk, Count Frontera picked up the empty letter and held up a pen.

"Whew."

The count's reluctant hands began to move, each stroke of writing containing a swelling amount of regret and sorriness.

Dear honorable Count Cordona, I pray for your perpetual glory to your honorable family. I cannot express the happiness I found myself in your kind proposal in the letter you sent me, and that alone has deepened the trust between our families. I also learned how an unexpected offer of hand from someone can be a source of great blessing. As such, my heart is filled with regret to no end. There are no words to express my sorrow. My heart is torn that I cannot form a special bond with your family, whose reputation and honor are well-known in the kingdom. Indeed, I am overwhelmed with grief as I write down this reply. It prompts me to wonder, is this what it feels like for the world to end? Therefore, please do not misunderstand my response. I sincerely express my gratitude for your proposal, but it is with profuse reluctance that I express my rejection... Blah blah blah... Despite that... Blah blah... Since my heart is sincere...

Just like that, the count wrote rejection letters through the night. The next day, 20 pigeons, carrying 59 regret-filled rejection letters, fluttered and left for the House of Peers in the palace.

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Chapter 159: Sweetness in the Air (2)

“It’s about the seventh operation in the east, Your Majesty.”

In the most luxurious and secretive conference room of the Magentano palace, Sir Elkamo read down the report with fierce eyes.

“First of all, Your Majesty, the previous operations focused on defeating the monster herd that caused damage in the eastern region, but the latest one concentrated on sweeping the remaining monsters in the areas that we have defeated.”

“And?” asked Queen Magentano.

“We have eliminated the remaining monsters in parts of the Sortino fiefdom and Adrano fiefdom. In the process, we have discovered three monster colonies that have settled in the borders of the Vasto fiefdom.”

“Was there,” the queen asked, “an unplanned battle?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“How was the damage on our side?”

“77 deaths and 182 injuries from the 20th infantry and 16 injuries from the ranger special forces, Your Majesty.”

“Those are considerable numbers.”

“I ask for your forgiveness,” said the secretary of the military and hung his head.

Sitting on the upper seat in the conference room, Queen Magentano waved her hands.

“It is not your fault, so do not be too distraught. Focus now on transporting the injured and dispatching additional troops to the area. Do your best in managing and dispatching the supplies.”

“Your words are my command.”

The secretary took his seat, and the queen secretly drew a sigh under her breath.

Damn those monsters.

The monster domino phenomenon had swept the entire eastern region, and the kingdom still suffered from the aftermath of the destructive disaster. Of course, there weren’t any more monsters laying siege. The phenomenon itself was over, but the issue was nonetheless still ongoing. That was because the monsters that crossed the eastern range remained instead of peacefully returning to where they came from after destroying the human fiefdoms. Instead, they settled and found homes in the regions ravaged by their attack.

And we cannot just let them be.

And so, the kingdom was at its seventh attempt in launching a large-scale sweeping operation against the monsters. But the end had yet to come. Queen Magentano, pinching the space between her eyes, looked at the secretary in charge of the kingdom’s internal affairs.

“Next,” she ordered.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Rising from his seat, the secretary reported to the queen about the reconstruction efforts in the east and the assistance given to Frontera county. Aside from that, many more reports were given to the queen. Once the representative of internal affairs was done, the speaker for external affairs stood, and in a slightly high-pitched tone, he reported the brazen response of the sultan kingdom in the east, how it still claimed innocence to the monster domino phenomenon, and how it dismissed it as an accident. The queen furrowed her brows as she heard the report.

Sultan... How brazen.

For a second, she wondered if she should resort to force or give him a final chance. Queen Magentano considered filing a formal complaint against the sultan kingdom and sending an envoy who could return with a diplomatic reward. Suddenly, one person came to her mind.

Lloyd Frontera.

She thought about putting the gutsy man in the delegation. Surprisingly, that idea didn't seem bad, and his sly silver tongue would be helpful. Moreover, sending Lloyd with the delegation sounded appropriate and reasonable, as Frontera county was one of the fiefdoms directly affected by the monster domino.

It sounds all right. I should consider it more seriously.

She was still deep in her thoughts when all the officials finished giving their report. Once it was over, she chaired a regular meeting for the next half a day. A small question popped into her head, and she decided to ask it later after the meeting was over. Once it did, she called the secretary of internal affairs, who was about to exit the conference room.

"I have a question I would like to ask you," said Queen Magentano.

"I am at your service, Your Majesty," said the secretary and waited for her to speak.

"The members of the nobility fall under the jurisdiction of the internal affairs, right?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"I have recently heard," continued the queen, "from a noble that a handful of proposal letters have been sent to Frontera county. Do you know what happened afterward?"

"Yes, Your Majesty. The response letters arrived at the House of Peers yesterday, and the letters were delivered to each family, Your Highness."

"I see."

Responses have arrived? Lloyd Frontera, that sly fox. I wonder what family he will choose to marry into.

She secretly wished that the family Lloyd would form a relationship with would be helpful to the reconstruction of the fiefdom. That way, the foundation of her kingdom would be more robust and act as a reliable shield in the east. As such, the queen was excited when she learned that the letters had arrived.

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A few more days later. The sludge treatment facility neared its completion. Its overall shape resembled a giant bucket buried in the earth. The process went like this: the basic concrete was firmly laid out on the ground, and a granite mold was inserted. The granite was a giant lump whose diameter reached over 50 yards, a product Javier had to laboriously and annoyingly sculpt and chisel for four days straight until it became bucket-shaped. This masterpiece was the body of the gravity thickener. Once it was finished, Bibeong moved the object to the treatment facility.

“Bibeobeong! Bibeong!”

Everyone cheered as Bibeong’s 3,000-ton buttock wiggled. Moving such a rock was not easy, even for him. Even if it was empty inside, the rock was still half the size of Bibeong. It was comparable to the struggle of pushing a car that ran out of gas a couple feet forward to get it to move again.

“Bibeo... beong!”

Bibeong sweated profusely on his feet, but he didn’t give up or express any difficulty. Why? The reason was simple. Bangul was there watching him.

“Bibeong!”

A true man, Bibeong believed, never appeared weak in front of his first love. Even when his back was about to snap in half, breathing became hard, and his legs trembled, he only wanted to show his good side to his crush. As a man, that was Bibeong’s sincerity towards his first love.

“Bibeo-beo-beo-beo-beong!”

He clenched his front teeth, and finally, he succeeded in planting the sludge thickener into the earth.

Bam! The sludge thickener fit into the ground with a rumble like a perfect puzzle piece. The sludge treatment facility was now completed. But the construction of the sewer wasn’t.

Sludge treatment requires a lot of water.

The principle was the same with the flush toilet, which needed constant running water. That was how lumps of bodily waste could travel to the sludge treatment facility. Otherwise, all the bodily waste and sludge would eventually dry up and stick to the pipes, piling up filth and clogging them. Once that happened...

No need to think about that...

Lloyd quickly pushed the thought away as he was going to lose his appetite. Anyway, from then on, Lloyd proceeded to construct the water pipes that extended from the Prona River to the shafts. This took five days. A portion of river water was made to travel through the pipe until it reached the shaft, which sat in the central village of the fiefdom, and flowed through the main sewer. This was the completion of the first section of the sewer. That day, Lloyd summoned the residents living in the central village.

“Okay, I am sure you all know why I gathered everyone here.”

The summer sun was fading, and about 300 residents gathered around, each holding a large bucket in their hands. Inside the bucket was...

“Did you all collect what I requested in advance?” asked Lloyd.

They nodded instead of speaking aloud. Every single one had towels or clothes over their nose and mouth. Not a single exception. Why? The bucket contained a few days of bodily waste and sewage. Lloyd quickly pinched his nose.

“Okay... Good job. From the smell, I can tell that everyone worked very hard to complete my request. I am pleased. We just have to successfully finish this test today. Then, you can stop collecting starting tomorrow since all the waste can be thrown away into this shaft right away. Got it?”

Everyone nodded, and this time, their nodding was more hurried than before. It was because of the stench. The weather was searingly hot, and the heat had fermented the bodily waste for several days. The stench was no less awful and terrorizing than any biological and chemical weapon. So, everyone hoped that Lloyd would skip his speech and save everyone. Lloyd didn’t betray their sincere wish.

“My gosh. I can barely breathe,” said Lloyd with a frown. “You all don’t mind if I skip the speech, right? Line up, everyone, and pour your buckets into the shaft one by one. But don’t rush. We don’t want them to splatter. Okay?”

Swoosh!

Once again, everyone was silent. Any more delay and their olfactory senses would start degrading. Everyone moved in a hurry instead of answering. The residents poured the bodily wastes that they meticulously collected for the past few days into the shaft. Later, Lloyd walked down into the shaft through the manhole together with Javier.

“Is there a reason why you had to come down yourself?” asked Javier.

“Of course.” Lloyd shrugged after he spoke. “I have to check with my own eyes whether the sewage travels well, and how it flows. Otherwise, it could turn into a disaster.”

Lloyd was telling the truth. Even if he built a giant sewer, he must never be relieved because this structure was a pathway for waste materials. As such, it was imperative to check whether it was solid and free from clogging.

“The thing with the sewage pipes is that you don’t notice they’re clogged until after a few days when a funky smell hits you or sewage surges out.

Once that happens, whew, it’s too late. It’ll probably be a hundred times harder to clear that than when we constructed the sewer,” said Lloyd.

That was the reason why Lloyd had personally come down here. He planned on checking whether the large volume of bodily waste the residents had just disposed of traveled to the sludge treatment facility without any problem. However, Javier remained serious and grim even if Lloyd kindly explained his presence.

“Then, is there a reason why I am down here with you?”

“Uh-huh,” drawled Lloyd.

“What is it?”

“It’s unfair if I’m the only one down here.”

“...”

“Cover your mouth and nose with this before you start to retch. But obviously, it won’t really matter if you do vomit. It’s going to flow along the sewer anyway,” said Lloyd with a mischievous smile as he held out a handkerchief to Javier.

Lloyd had already covered his lips and nose tightly with a towel. That was the only way for him to breathe. But even so, it was still hard to breathe.

This is seriously no joke.

Dozens of feet under the ground, Lloyd and Javier were walking along the narrow sewage pipe that led to the main sewer. It was so narrow that the sidewalk only had room for one person, and a large volume of rotten and fermented sewage buoyed away beside. The mere sight of it churned both of their stomachs. The stench was worsened due to the lack of ventilation, and since Lloyd was a mid-level sword expert, his heightened senses agitated him even more than before.

This is nuts. If I could, I’d get rid of my nose. No, I just want to reset my manaheart skill. The heck with being a sword expert. I take it all back.

Covering his face with a towel barely worked. It was torturous. How bad was it? Lloyd was as tormented as when he entered a gas-filled CBRN room at his military boot camp and removed his mask to let the tear gas assault his senses, jumping up and down and singing the national anthem. So, Lloyd made a resolution.

If ever I have the chance, I'll reject leveling up as a sword expert.

Actually, Lloyd had planned to stay at his current level even without this experience. It was because of the sword master syndrome.

Javier had terrible insomnia because of that.

All your senses became so sensitive that they pushed past human limits. So much so that you couldn't control their heightened senses. For 24 hours a day, you could hear everything around you, even the sound of a needle dropping to the ground. Furthermore, all your other senses like smell or touch were equally heightened. It was the same for your vision.

Your eyes become as sharp as an eagle's. You can even see the pores of the person in front of you.

Lloyd wondered if Javier had been perceiving him that way all along. Chills ran down his spine. Lloyd shook his head and turned around to face Javier.

"Here, aren't you going to take this?"

Javier didn't accept the towel Lloyd held out to him. But his face appeared too calm and nonchalant without it. Lloyd was about to ask why when Javier spoke first.

"I am all right," said Javier.

"Really? Are you sure?"

"Yes."

Javier nodded with a scoff on his face.

“I have blocked my sense of smell the moment I entered here with you.”

“You blocked it...?” asked Lloyd, goggle-eyed. “Your sense of smell? On purpose?”

“Yes.”

“How is that possible?”

“Well, since I am a sword master...”

“Are you saying that you’re not smelling this stench at all?”

“No.”

Lloyd was dumbfounded.

“Actually, I can adjust my senses and change the stench to a floral scent.”

“Good for you,” blurted Lloyd.

“Thank you,” said Javier with a smile.

“...”

All of a sudden, Lloyd was gripped by the desire to flop down and throw a tantrum, but he had to walk ahead nonetheless even when all his happiness was draining out of him with every passing second. Lloyd and Javier walked along the long pathway filled with bodily wastes and sewage from more than 300 people. They ambled to the sludge treatment facility and observed and studied the inside of the main sewer. The outcome greatly satisfied Lloyd.

Good. There’s no blockage at all. Everything’s flowing smoothly like a drain cleaner was used.

From that moment onward, Lloyd entrusted the remaining sections of the sewer construction to Sir Bayern. He instructed that the shaft be built in the remaining villages, the apartment complex, and the count manor.

The bodily wastes collected from the shafts will travel through the Cholera canal sewer pipes, the main sewer, and then, finally, arrive at the sludge treatment facility.

This was the sewage system Lloyd had designed. Time passed by, and the structure expanded one section at a time. One day, two days, ten days, two weeks... Meanwhile, the residents in the central village, who were the first to enjoy the sewage system, continued to produce bodily wastes and toss them into the shaft. As days passed by, sewage started to pile up at the sludge treatment facility, and about a month later, when the solid and liquid waste became completely separated...

Kaboom! Solitas breathed fire at the northern border of the fiefdom after opening the lid of the sludge treatment facility. The lump of the sludge was made to float in the air with magic. Solitas breathed out hellish fire at the lump.

...!

Flames measuring tens of thousands of degrees engulfed the lump of bodily wastes produced by roughly 300 residents in the central village. Then, not giving the stench any time to spread, it was scorched to ashes in a flash. Just then, a welcoming message appeared in front of Lloyd’s eyes.

Ding Dong!

[You have successfully constructed a collective sewage treatment system for the first time in the Lorasian continent with your mysterious foresight, delicate engineering knowledge, and assistance of the strongest race on earth.]

[The Lorasian continent encounters the concept of “public health” for the first time in history due to the sewer system you have constructed.]

[Your impressive accomplishment will be passed down for many generations.]

[You earned a new title reflecting the blood, sweat, tear, and resentment of future civil engineering and public health students.]

[A new title <Red Pill or Blue Pill> has been created.]

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Chapter 160: Sweetness in the Air (3)

Ding dong.

[A new title <Red Pill or Blue Pill> has been created.]

A welcoming message floated in front of Lloyd's eyes, just as he had expected.

Well, I knew this would happen since I completed the first section of the sewage system and the very first sludge treatment.

It was always like this. Even when he reclaimed the Maritz Wetlands and terraced the fields using the retaining walls. The system didn't award him with any honors or titles just because he completed a construction. It was only after he had used the structures to accomplish something that he was rewarded.

I wonder what this title is about.

He wanted to know what kind of sweet effect it has. Expectant, Lloyd moved his eyes.

[Do you want the red or blue pill?]

[Title Level: Kingdom History]

A long, long time ago. In a remote fiefdom in the east, there lived a petty young master. This young master, owning such a foul and warped character, stuck his nose in everyone's business, even regarding their bathroom habits. People thus then asked, young master, my dear young master, why must we collect our poop and throw it here? The young master enthusiastically waved his hands and said, it's smelly, so you might as well hurry. They tilted their heads. But a few years later, they realized. They realized that their villages, fiefdoms, and fields no longer held traces of any infectious disease. From the moment the news

spread, people from all over the kingdom, most of the residents in the fiefdom no longer disposed of their wastes anywhere they could.

[Compliment Effect: The chances of an infectious disease plaguing the fiefdom are zero for the time being. Moreover, any infectious disease that starts outside the fiefdom will be stopped and eradicated with 100% certainty.]

[Title Region: Frontera county.]

[Active Period of Title: 50 Years.]

[A title's powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region for which the compliment was given. Moreover, the time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 6]

[Current CP: 218]

Woah.

Lloyd covered his mouth with his hand once he read the compliment title.

This is awesome.

Lloyd had secretly hoped for a good option, but this reward exceeded his expectations by a mile. A zero probability of a disease outbreak. In other words, the title signaled the complete prevention of the cholera outbreak slated to occur in the coming spring.

Now, even if it's not cholera, it doesn't matter. Any epidemic will be prevented.

It was mind-blowing to every extent. Actually, Lloyd wasn't utterly relieved despite the ongoing construction. Nervousness lingered in the corner of his heart because he couldn't guarantee that the impending epidemic he saw through the Ending Spoiler was cholera.

It's not like I'm a public health expert or anything. I just presumed that it was cholera based on several circumstantial pieces of evidence.

So, there was a slight possibility that the plague he saw wasn't cholera, which was why Lloyd planned on using the Ending Spoiler once more after the sewage system construction to check.

Of course I will. My life depends on it.

He couldn't relax and laze around just because he completed the sewers. As the old saying went, he needed to look before he leaped. Lloyd had to inspect if his work prevented the epidemic from striking the fiefdom in the coming spring. But not anymore. There was no need to.

The possibility of an epidemic is zero. 100% guaranteed prevention of an epidemic. On top of that, this will continue for the next 50 years.

It was perfect. He wouldn't die next spring from a disease. There wasn't a reason to use the Ending Spoiler anymore.

And I got to save some CP as a result.

That really pleased Lloyd as well. In any case, he wanted to save as much CP as he could. CP was hard to come by, and the Ending Spoiler required a lot of it.

Unlike RP, it's hard to save up CP. The former is like a regular wage that comes each time I increase my likeability or accomplish something. The latter is similar to a salary that is only released once a month.

And he merely received 36 CP every month, but what was the price of the Ending Spoiler?

A whopping 80 CP. To just use it once! What about after that? I'd have to spend 160 since the price doubles with each try. And the one after that would cost me 320.

What if he thoughtlessly used the Ending Spoiler right now? Later on, he would need to spend hundreds of CP to just get a glimpse of the future,

which would take several months, or worse, years to save.

That would be troublesome.

That would prevent him from using the skill when he needed it most. But now, thanks to the effect of the title he just earned, he avoided wasting his CP and doubling the CP price for the Ending Spoiler. Killing two birds with one stone, Lloyd swelled with satisfaction, so he grinned at Solitas, who morphed back to a human after breathing fire as a dragon.

“Thank you,” said Lloyd. “You took a large weight off my shoulders.”

“Well, no need to thank me.”

“Please, you have been a great help.”

“Have I?”

Phew. Solitas licked his lips, his mouth growing bitter. He was swamped with work as he doubled down on his craftsmanship these days. It was only yesterday that he received a compliment from Corgidus, his teacher, for his ability to chisel wood blocks, albeit telling him it was narrowly acceptable. His days were quite rewarding. That was why he didn’t think much when Lloyd called him, shoved the outsourcing contract, and brought him to the sludge treatment facility.

He simply thought that he was doing his job, paying back for the crafting lessons. As such, he shifted to his original shape, let out a breath, and turned a couple of tons of bodily waste into ashes. It was only then that Solitas was hit with a pang of bitterness, which was as acute and deep as a shot of espresso. A sense of shame overwhelmed his dragon heart. Solitas couldn’t believe that he was reduced to a human dung cleaner when he was born a proud dragon. From what he heard, there would be even more poop in the future, including from orcs and elves. Solitas was scared particularly with the latter. He had heard their poop had a vile smell as a result of their carnivore diet.

What am I doing with my life?

Solitas felt dismayed to the deepest part of his soul. He felt like he had become an abbreviated piece of nothing in this vast universe. If there was any value in him at the moment, he was nothing but a high-tech, advanced waste burner.

“…”

Solitas wondered if he should call it quits and give up on dating and marriage. Should I go back to the lair? He mused, considering living the life of a bachelor dragon. A healthy and beautiful soul liberated from the considerations and silliness of life. Just like that, Solitas was getting strongly drawn to the powerful epiphany that struck him now. However, just then...

“By the way, oh, how I wish I could travel to the Cordona region on a day like this.”

Lloyd’s voice interrupted his resentful trance. Sensing he was brought back to reality, Solitas furrowed his brows and spoke.

“Cordona?” he asked, “Where is it?”

“Eh? Don’t you know?”

“Of course, I don’t...”

“It’s a popular honeymoon destination that’s been trending these days,” Lloyd said.

“What?”

Honeymoon. The word made Solitas flinch. Dating and marriage. Unaccomplished dreams. Hopes and sorrow, though faint, poked Solitas’s heart, and the word “honeymoon” heightened his fading desires a little more.

“I heard,” Lloyd continued to say, “it is known for its gentle and beautiful landscape all throughout the year. I heard that the ‘Hot Spring Beach’ is especially popular among newlyweds.”

“Hot Spring? Beach?”

“Yes. It’s a unique sandy beach that has a hot spring.”

“What? A sandy beach with a hot spring?” gaped the dragon.

“Yes. That’s what I heard. They said that you can just go anywhere on the beach with a shovel and dig until you take a bath. And once you do, people say spring water will surge from the ground. Then, et voila, there’s a hot spring bath for you and your loved one.”

Gulp. Solitas’s neck bobbed when he imagined it. Lloyd continued to speak, his words flowing out of him like sweet honey.

“There’s more. It’s said that the Cordona region sees a downpour that lasts exactly an hour at midnight due to seasonal wind patterns.”

“Downpour? That does not sound very nice,” said the dragon.

“No, it’s actually very good.”

“How so?”

“Think about it. You go on a dip with your lover in the hot spring water, gazing at the stars in the sky. Then, it starts to pour. Your body is warm in the water. Your shoulders and face are cool from the rain. And your ears are filled with the sweet melody of the ocean waves.”

“Oh? Ah...” gulped Solitas.

“Can you imagine?”

Nod. Solitas found himself clenching his fists, and the resentment and bitterness that overwhelmed his heart were now gone. In its stead, there was only passionate determination, even more intense than before.

I’ll get married and go to the rainy hot spring!

Now, his dream had become more detailed. Solitas became determined to exterminate human poop, orc poop, elf poop, and anything else. He could infinitely incinerate them to achieve his dream. Lloyd's eyes held a glint of satisfaction as they looked at the dragon.

"Whew," sighed Lloyd. "I wish I could visit a place like that. Don't you agree?"

"I do..."

Lloyd succeeded in appeasing the dragon, whose troubled mind needed some calming. Lloyd returned to the manor, his steps light.

It looks like I'll be able to relax for the time being.

Before he knew it, summer was coming to an end. The sun still beat down the fiefdom with its scorching heat, but Lloyd felt it getting slowly shorter. A few months from now, and the fiefdom would be covered by red fall leaves to give way to snow.

I have enough time.

The construction of the remaining sections took place seamlessly, and the apartment complexes were getting erected without any problem. These two projects would be finished before winter arrived. And now that the predestined epidemic was gone, Lloyd didn't have much to worry about.

I just need to make a little more money to keep as a sort of pension. It makes *me a bit nervous to be dependent on the water bill and the queen's support. Once I find another source of income, I can live my life as a couch potato.*

Lloyd patted himself on the back for the recent bone-breaking work he had finished. And for some reason, he was especially exhausted tonight. Was it because he verified his accomplishment and the outcome of his efforts with his own eyes? Was it because all his pent-up tension was now gone? Exhaustion, which had built inside him over the past few months of hard, self-negating work, came crashing down on him tonight.

Let’s eat, take a bath, and get a good night’s sleep. Tomorrow and the day after that as well, if I can.

Lloyd thought about taking a break for the next few days. Such life was something he could only dream of when he was in South Korea, living in a rental room. As such, Lloyd decided to actualize his dream and enjoy every second of his break. But the moment he stepped into the manor, he was confronted with an unexpected spectacle at the main chamber of the first floor.

“Huh?”

Lloyd spotted Count Frontera chatting with a lady he had never seen before. She seemed to be in her early 20s. Decked out in flashy clothes and ornaments, she didn’t appear to be a maid or a peasant. And she sided with a man who seemed to be her guard knight.

A noble?

Not a hair out of place with a knight escorting her. She certainly was a noble.

But what’s a noble lady doing here?

It was around the time Lloyd had that thought that the lady’s gaze traveled to his side. She then put on a courteous smile.

“I presume you are Lloyd Frontera,” she greeted.

Lloyd nodded rather reluctantly.

“Yes, I am. But who are you?” asked Lloyd.

“It is a pleasure to finally come to your acquaintance. My name is Carlotta Cordona of the Cordona family.”

A bad, sinister feeling gripped Lloyd as he quizzed himself about her presence here. Soon, he was confirmed.

“Um, do not be surprised,” said Count Frontera. “I am sure you remember that you received a letter of proposal a few days ago. After receiving my response, Count Cordona sent his daughter here.”

“Excuse me? Why?” Lloyd blurted out in shock, but it was Lady Cordona who answered.

“It appears that my father still has a bit of hope for the marriage offer. That is why he pushed me to come here.”

“…”

Lloyd pieced things together in his head. It appeared that his rejection was returned with one more chance to talk about the marriage. That was why Count Cordona sent his daughter here.

Is this how he appeals? Gosh, the man is quite aggressive.

Just then, Lloyd broke out in a cold sweat. It never occurred to him that anyone would actually send his daughter after getting rejected. Calming his flustered heart, Lloyd turned to Count Frontera.

“Um, did you not send a clear letter of rejection?” asked Lloyd.

“Um, um, you see, I did, but...”

“…”

“I, too, am surprised by this. Hahaha.”

Count Frontera laughed with evident embarrassment on his face. He was sincerely flustered because he, too, never imagined this situation to happen.

Did I express my rejection too vaguely? But I definitely did reject him without a doubt. Or could it be that the letter exuded the immense regrets I had? That could be it.

A pang of guilt poked a corner of his heart. Count Frontera wondered if he should reveal to his son that the culprit was his vague response. Just then,

while this internal debate was taking place, Lady Cordona smiled softly and stepped forward.

“Please do not be too troubled,” she said.

“Excuse me?” Lloyd cocked his head to the side. “What do you mean by that?”

“To be frank,” continued Lady Cordona, “I do not intend to go through an arranged marriage. And as I have told you, I came here with a reluctant heart. I could not resist my father’s insistence.”

“Oh...”

“So, please do not be troubled. Do permit me to be indebted to your family by spending a few nights so my father will be satisfied. I will quietly reside during my time here and then return.”

“Do you mean that?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes,” Lady Cordona nodded with confidence. Lloyd clenched his fist in joy in his heart.

Th-thank goodness.

Lloyd was scared that he would have to suddenly deal with the issue of marriage, which he didn’t care for at all. But contrary to his concern for the unexpected storm, the lady was cool and calm, to his relief.

“I see,” said Lloyd, “please make yourself at home for the next few days.”

“Thank you.”

After a formal handshake with the lady, Lloyd returned to his bedroom with a lighter heart and sprawled on the bed.

Dating or whatever. I’m not interested. I want to rest. I’m just going to enjoy my free time and relax.

And so, Lloyd decided that it was time to get a good night's sleep. He would sleep in the next day too. Just like that, he fell asleep in peace. But when the morning rolled around, the peaceful Frontera manor received four more visits by the ladies of different families.

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Chapter 161: Predicted Disaster (1)

“Bibeong!”

There came a ringing and clear shout of Bibeong from Lake Kapua in the eastern mountain range, announcing the arrival of the morning across the Frontera county.

“Hmm...”

It was an unusually refreshing morning for Lloyd, for it had been quite a while since he slept this well. The first thing that crossed his mind when he opened his eyes was...

Why do I always wake up so easily when I’m on vacation?

It was truly strange. And it had always been like this. On school days, forcing his eyes open in the morning couldn’t be any more difficult. But strangely, he rose automatically on days there wasn’t any school. The same thing was happening today.

I have nothing to busy myself with for a while.

Lying on the floor, Lloyd recollected the events in his fiefdom. The apartment complex construction had gone smoothly. The project picked up its pace after Building 103 was finished because every building looked exactly the same as the other as if they were copy pasted. And as the workers grew more experienced and accustomed to the job, the increased speed in their work translated to better performance and results.

And so, I can just entrust the job to them from now on.

The same went for the construction of the sewers. The main sewer and the sludge treatment facility, the central parts of the sewage system, were already completed. The only thing left was to construct shafts across the villages, apartment complexes, and sewage pipes. Then, connect the shafts to the main sewer.

That can be left to them as well. I just need to do the inspection.

Long live Sir Bayern. Long, long live the engineers, elves, and orcs. What a great blessing that he had a huge, reliable team and a system that allowed construction to progress on its own without requiring his intervention.

But, of course, our funds are a bit lacking.

A slight wrinkle appeared between Lloyd's brows as he lazed around his bed. If he was being honest, the fiefdom's finances weren't always enough. There were just too many things to spend on. First, there were tens of thousands of refugees. The cost to feed and clothe them was unimaginable. But the terraced fields in the eastern range had only taken their first step.

Sure, there is the water bill from Lacona viscounty, some other minor funds, and the aid from the palace... But we don't have enough.

Lloyd first thought that they had enough, but after a string of large-scale constructions, he realized it wasn't sufficient at all. So, if he ever got the chance, he needed to acquire a stable source of money.

It's not like the palace is going to assist us forever.

The royal support they received could be cut off anytime. Though the palace said it wouldn't under the queen's promise, the world was full of surprises. Promises weren't the only thing that the universe listened to.

Who knows. There could be a natural disaster, political upheaval, or war that puts the entire palace at risk.

As such, there was always the chance that the support they received from the palace could be cut off. Then, his fiefdom would inevitably die of hunger. Lloyd wanted to avoid such a situation as much as possible. If he could, he wanted to acquire a more stable source of income.

But... I can think about that tomorrow. Tomorrow.

Today, he would really just relax. After all, he had worked on all sorts of projects in the past few months, from the apartment complex to the

retaining walls and sewers. Lloyd was filled with exhaustion, feeling as if his body was being torn into several pieces. While Lloyd tossed and turned with that thought in mind, and as his bed creaked, someone knocked on his door.

Knock knock knock.

“Master Lloyd, do you wish to eat your meal inside your room?”

There came knocking on his bedroom door. It was followed by a maid’s question. He didn’t notice that it was breakfast time already. Rising up from bed, he hurried and put on his shirt.

“Yeah, come in.”

The door opened to reveal the maid carrying a tray in her hands. It was Emily, whom Lloyd was familiar with among the manor's maids.

“How was your sleep, young master?”

“Good,” he said, “Have you been waiting at the door with that tray until I made a noise?”

“I didn’t wait too long,” replied Emily with a grin on her face as though she was telling Lloyd that it was nothing.

“But Master Lloyd,” Emily continued as she placed the sausage, egg, salad, and hot milk off the tray. “I am not sure what you will make of what I will say, but it must be so nice, young master.”

“Hm? Me? Why?” said Lloyd quizzically.

“Why else, young master? Such a gentle and friendly lady has traveled here to propose,” she answered.

“Oh, her?” Lloyd chuckled involuntarily, his thoughts flying back to Lady Cordona he met shortly after the previous day. Indeed, Lloyd thought to himself, she was very courteous and cool. It appeared that Emily felt the same about her.

“Sure, but what can I do? Lady Cordona nor I am not interested in an arranged marriage.”

Lloyd spoke with a bitter smile, but this brought Emily to cock her head to the side.

“Um, but I was speaking of Lady Perano.”

“What?” asked Lloyd.

“Oh, I forgot.”

Emily then clapped her hands, and she added as though she forgot to tell Lloyd something, “Come to think of it, I suppose you haven’t met her yet. That is, Lady Perano.”

“Hold on... Lady Perano? Who is that?”

“She came early in the morning,” Emily answered.

“Early in the morning?”

“Yes, young master. Very early. Before the sunrise.”

“Very early. Before the sunrise. While I was asleep”? repeated Lloyd.

“Yes, yes, young master,” said Emily. “I woke up early because I was in charge of drawing water at dawn. That’s how I saw her. She had twelve knights in a very fancy carriage. Even then, how gentle and kind she was.”

“Woah... Hold on. Hold on right there.”

In a panic, Lloyd wondered what Emily was saying.

“I’m still trying to grasp the bomb you dropped on me, so let me ask you one thing,” said Lloyd.

“Yes, Young Master.”

“Could you be saying now that someone else other than Lady Cordona came here? In the early morning?”

“Yes, Young Master. She is having breakfast with the count at the moment.”

“...”

“Young master?”

Lloyd jumped out of bed, his heart pounding violently. This is nuts! Lloyd shouted internally, thinking that he was wrong to believe everything was taken care of after the situation with Lady Cordona was resolved. He was seriously mistaken. The marriage issue hadn’t been solved. Lloyd feared that the issue would blow out of control like wildfire. He started to put on his shoes before he knew it.

“Yeah, Emily. I’m sorry. I think I need to get going,” said Lloyd.

“Young master?”

“I need to go there right now. No, I need to fix this situation. I'll eat it in the dining room.”

“Then, what about this food-”

“You eat it,” said Lloyd.

“Excuse me?”

“Eat for me. But don’t tell the others. Okay?”

“Oh, young master-”

“There shouldn’t be any leftovers,” interrupted Lloyd.“You’ll get punished. In hell, they’ll mix up all of your life’s leftovers and make you eat it.”

“...”

Lloyd got out of his bedroom, leaving Emily, whose face was becoming pale. Lloyd quickened his steps down to the dining room.

***

“Woah.”

The morning passed by like a storm. No, to be exact, a mind-boggling lunchtime had come.

“So... was that when you stopped hesitating to firmly give a blunt rejection during your first encounter with the ladies?”

“Uh-huh.”

Lloyd and Javier were near the main gate of the Frontera manor. Slouching on the wooden bench like wet laundry, he nodded.

“What’s the point of beating around the bush?” said Lloyd.

“Was it to avoid any misunderstandings?” asked Javier.

“Uh-huh.”

Lloyd nodded his head again at Javier’s question. Just then, he recalled what he had gone through in the morning.

“So, when I came down to the dining room, Lady Perano, who arrived at dawn, greeted me with a bright smile on her face. But the atmosphere was just, whew.”

“What was it like for you to react this way?”

“Just one nod from me, and she was ready to settle in here.”

“So?”

“I spoke by reflex because the situation didn’t feel right.”

“What did you say?”

“Nothing special. I flatly told her to enjoy her stay here for a few days and go back since I don’t have any intention to marry her.”

“Your rejection was too straightforward. I wouldn’t be surprised if Lady Perano was offended,” Javier said.

“That’s probably why she berated me with a smile on her face.”

“What was it about?”

“She said that she came here with high expectations but was disappointed when she actually saw me,” answered Lloyd.

“Why?”

“She said she couldn’t tell whether I look like this because I took a weird drug or didn’t take the one I need.”

“It appears the answer is the latter,” said Javier.

“I don’t need you to answer that question...”

“Anyway,” Javier went on ignoring Lloyd, “is that how you also treated the two ladies that came after her?”

“Yeah. I gave my rejection as soon as I saw their faces. I was insulted twice more, thanks to it.”

What Lloyd said did take place. After Lady Perano, the ones that came next in the morning were Lady Esperia and Lady Sicily. Lloyd rejected them the moment they stepped out of their carriage. Feeling severely mortified, the ladies hurled curses at Lloyd. He did feel that he was being severe on them. But he couldn’t do anything else as he was able to slightly presume why this unfortunate event took place.

The count likely gave a vague, ambiguous response.

Though he wasn’t certain, the circumstances pointed in that direction.

The count was very wistful when I asked him to reject the marriage proposals.

Lloyd figured that the count’s reluctance could be seen in his response, leading the recipients to form misguided thoughts.

That’s why the families started to second guess themselves even after receiving a rejection letter. They must have felt that pushing us once more would change my answer. And so, out of such hope, these powerful and wealthy families sent their daughters directly here. They put their trust in the reputation of their family. That is, to obtain my acceptance.

So, Lloyd decided that his answer this time could not be ambiguous. Even if he was a little rude, he had to be firm and straightforward, like a straight shooter. His rejection had to be as sharp as a blade. That was how he could avoid dragging things out and make sure that the other parties would give up soon. Lloyd thought that was the best for both of them.

“Anyway,” Lloyd continued, “I am full. I am not hungry at all, even though I skipped breakfast and lunch. I wonder if all those insults made me lose my appetite.”

Lloyd laughed aloud as he spoke, and Javier chuckled.

“If that was the case, you should be full all the time.”

“Hmm? Why?”

“Thanks to me,” said Javier.

“What? Wait, do you always insult me inside your head?”

“Obviously.”

“Wow. You aren’t even trying to deny it.”

“Sincerity and honesty are the virtues of a knight,” defended Javier.

“Can you at least pretend at a time like this?”

“I cannot.”

“How firm you are.”

“I appreciate the compliment.”

“Forget it. Oh, there. There’s another one coming.”

The usual banter between them came to a halt. Lloyd’s gaze traveled down the hill, and he saw a carriage driving up the sloped approach. It wasn’t a cargo cart. Decked out with flashy ornaments, four white horses led the carriage, and even the horseman was cleanly dressed. Around it were eight knights on horses. It was noble for sure, and it went without saying why they were coming here.

“Woah. She is the fourth person to come today alone.”

Lloyd wondered what kind of insults this lady would hurl at him. Does your breath smell like hot trash? Or do I want to alter your face by punching you so many times? Lloyd got up from the bench, feeling strangely expectant. Meanwhile, the carriage climbed the hill, and he stopped at the entrance.

The eight knights queued up, and the horseman grabbed the door handle. The gold-rimmed door slowly opened, and Lloyd gulped at the same time. He then got ready, the words of rejection right behind his lips. But when he looked at the lady appearing from the door, Lloyd flinched involuntarily.

Eh?

Even though his brain told him to shoot the words of rejection before the greeting, he couldn’t do it. Was it because he fell in love with her? Was she his ideal woman? No. He stopped because he knew who she was.

The Knight of Blood and Iron. The novel contained a couple of illustrations, and I saw her in one of them.

Lloyd searched for his memory in which part he saw it. Which scene? The lady's heels clacked as they touched the ground. That revived the searching piece of memory.

She wasn't a villain.

She was a protagonist, but a pitiful one. She sacrificed herself for many people. She threw her life away, her sacrifice granting Javier a chance to fight back. The unbreakable wall crumbled to save countless people and prevent catastrophe. That place of incident was...

"Naraman county. Siluria Namaran."

Lloyd's words came out on their own against his will as the memory recovered. The lady grew wide-eyed as she heard it.

"Excuse me? Do you know me?"

"..."

Lloyd intensely stared at her instead of giving a response. In the story, people in the city were on the brink of getting sacrificed by the warlocks. Javier then invented the mana blast for the first time ever to prevent the disaster. But there was one lady Javier failed to save from meeting a tragic end. That was Siluria Namaran, and she was now grinning at Lloyd.

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Chapter 162: Predicted Disaster (2)

Namaran's Wall. It appeared in the middle of the novel, and Lloyd found it the most impressive part of the story. The powers of the dark magicians were finally unveiled to clash with Javier for the first time. Lloyd's mind flew back to the part of the story.

The dark magicians tried to sacrifice all the people in the city as they enclosed the city walls with a powerful magical barrier.

The magical wall was impenetrable, and that remained true no matter how much Javier tried. Perhaps, it was thanks to the hardship and danger then that the mana blast, which was the most advanced piece of technology in the novel, was invented right in front of Namaran's Wall.

Javier clashed a mana circle for the first time as he went beyond his limits to use his mana to penetrate the wall. It was by chance that Javier instinctively understood to blast the power coming from the clash.

That was the birth of Javier's signature skill, the mana blast. He mixed the aura with the mana blast, and the indomitable Naraman's Wall finally came down. Javier and the Naraman knights entered the castle. The battle dragged out for about two days. In the end, Javier got rid of the dark magicians and saved the people in there except for one. The only daughter of Count Namaran. She sacrificed herself when one of the dark magicians attempted to summon Hell's Knight as he clung to his last straw. Thanks to her sacrifice, Javier stopped attempting to summon the knight who could overpower even a sword master and was about to confirm his victory.

I think Javier's victory was made possible by her sacrifice.

Jolted out of his trance, Lloyd lifted his head and looked at the lady standing before him. She was cocking her head to the side with a grin on her face.

"I believe you murmured my name just a while ago. Did I hear it wrong?"

Siluria Namaran.

Lloyd had felt like this before. A strange feeling always swelled over him when he personally encountered a figure he only saw in illustrations. It was the case when he first met Javier. And right now. It was terribly more so right now when he knew what tragic fate awaited this character in the story. But now wasn't the time to be engrossed in such emotions. Lloyd quickly removed the restlessness that was coming up in him and put on a plastic smile.

"Oh, please forgive me. What a blunder to commit to our first meeting. My name is Lloyd Frontera, and welcome to Frontera county."

"You are the rumored young master Frontera," Siluria said.

"Indeed. I am the rumored hooligan."

"How modest you are," she said, "and you already know my name."

"Oh, I saw the symbol engraved in the carriage."

"You have sharp eyes," she said.

"And my head is growing from your compliments."

Lloyd shrugged after he spoke.

It's a bit worrisome, really.

Lloyd thought to himself as she looked at the lady in front of her. Just then, he became curious. He wondered if that disastrous incident about the Namaran's Wall took place here.

Though Namaran isn't in the east, it's still not very far.

Technically speaking, the city was located in the mountainous area between the east and south. But if something did take place over there, his fiefdom would be affected as well.

I need to go and check over it.

Actually, there was enough chance that the events in the novel would not take place in real life. A lot of things deviated from the story. Lloyd was alive, and Javier was here. Queen Magentano didn't lose her arm. The period and result of the monster domino effect were changed. Port Cremo was cleared off the Gigatitan to be prosperous, and the Frontera fiefdom, which was only a provincial village in the story, came to house a host of refugees and became the city in charge of reconstruction. Like this, this world underwent countless changes. Namaran could be the same. The tragic incident in the novel might not happen. With such hope in his heart, Lloyd spoke and asked a question.

"Tell me, is renowned gentleman Cannavaro at your estate?" asked Lloyd.

"I beg your pardon?" Lady Namaran's eyes widened.

"From what I heard," said Lloyd as though he was testing her. "A wealthy man by the name of Cannavaro is doing philanthropic activities in Namaran. I personally have a lot of respect for him."

The truth was that Cannavaro in question was a dark magician, the culprit behind the Naraman tragedy. But at this period in time, he was disguising himself as a regular wealthy man.

Like so, he makes a great name for himself. How? By personally taking in a considerable number of migrants and covering their expenses.

In the novel, once Queen Magentano turned into a tyrant, the southern region attempted a coup against the queen. That brought about a cruel, large-scale suppression effort, displacing an alarming number of people in the process. Some of them arrived at Namaran, and it was Cannavaro who took care of them. But did he do so out of compassion? Of course not.

It was mentioned in the story that it was so he could use them to experiment with dark magic.

But right now, things had changed. Queen Magentano was A-OK, and there was no coup in the south.

So, Cannavaro doesn't have any way to accept people under his care.

And his fame won't be able to grow anymore. In other words, Lady Namaran had to answer his question, saying, "Cannavaro? Who is that?" That would assure Lloyd that the place would be safe for a while, as it meant the warlock couldn't test his magic out yet.

Which means that I don't have to worry too much about the people down there. Tell me you've never heard of Cannavaro! Now!

Lloyd begged internally. Just then, Lady Namaran smiled brightly.

"Oh, mister Cannavaro? How surprising. Has his reputation spread all the way here already?" answered Lady Namaran.

"Excuse me?" gaped Lloyd.

"He is an excellent man. It is never easy to care for the destitute. It's a difficult job for any normal person regardless of their wealth."

"By the destitute, you mean..."

"The people who suffered from the tragedy that happened in the east. I am sure you know of it as well, right? The monster domino effect."

"Oh." And that was it for Lloyd.

"Yes, that is right. Some of the refugees came to Namaran in the aftermath of the disaster. About 400 people, I'm guessing. My father tried to take care of them at first, and that is when mister Cannavaro volunteered."

"To take care of the refugees?"

"Yes, he did. What an amazing man. However, he cannot be compared to Count Frontera, who is feeding and housing tens of thousands of refugees here."

“Haha, you flatter us.”

Lloyd swallowed dryly.

Crap. More than 400?

The number of people was significantly more than in the original story, which was only 100. In short, the situation was set to be worse than it was previously.

Crap. Crap!

Lloyd had an ominous feeling.

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“Whew. My goodness.”

Lloyd flopped on the sofa after he came back to his bedroom. The pressure of his body caused the sofa to let out an airy noise. His sigh was the same.

I succeeded in rejecting her, but I’m not happy at all.

He thought about Lady Namaran, with whom he had chatted a while ago. Once they moved on from discussing the situation in Namaran and Cannavaro, Lloyd quickly said that he had no plans to tie the knot with her family. Thank you for traveling a long way, so make yourself at home, he said unilaterally. This was the sole reason he had waited for her in front of the manor at first. Sure, the Namaran incident was serious, but what was equally serious was a forced marriage. Thankfully, Lady Namaran’s reaction couldn’t be any calmer. She revealed that she, too, traveled up here by the passionate urging of her family and thanked Lloyd for being frank. The pressure was now gone, she said with a bright and pristine smile on her face.

“...”

So, Lloyd was bothered all the more. Lady Namaran, who just smiled at Lloyd, could wind up in a mishap and die.

Should I warn her in advance?

The thought crossed his mind, but he realized it wasn't a smart idea upon more reflection. This Cannavaro figure's fame was skyrocketing at the moment. No one would believe that he was actually an evil warlock. It would be Lloyd who would be considered a fool. Besides, he didn't have clear evidence to prove the man's evil plans as there was no exact explanation in the story of how the wall was made.

Should I just turn a blind eye?

He lay on the sofa and blankly stared at the ceiling. To be honest, he didn't want to care. But how could he not? Ignoring the situation could have a huge consequence on his fiefdom.

Hell's Knight.

This knight from hell was the entity that warlock Cannavaro attempted to summon by offering the people's lives. What if nobody stopped it from happening? What if Hell's Knight was summoned, unlike the novel? That hellish situation would be on another level compared to what happened with the monster domino effect.

The story says that Hell's Knight can overpower sword masters.

They didn't directly appear in the novel, but Javier mentioned them to himself in the latter part of the story. He said that even though he was a grandmaster, he stood no chance of winning against Hell's Knight without the Asrahan Core Technique.

In other words, Hell's Knight is almost the same as an ordinary grandmaster.

Even Javier stood no chance at this period. It would be so even if there were ten Javiers. That was how destructive and powerful a grandmaster was.

I must stop him from coming into this world at all costs.

If he didn’t, it meant the destruction of Namaran and the entire country. It would be impossible for Lloyd’s fiefdom to survive in those circumstances.

Dammit. What should I do? Send Javier to Namaran? No. What if that changes the story? But it already has. The change might be the reason why I can’t stop the incident.

If possible, he had to head to Namaran himself. That was the only way for him to actively respond to the changing situation. So, he needed to come up with an excuse to go there.

Should I just say that I want to travel there for vacation? But that’s a bit strange. Hmm.. ask Lady Namaran to pretend to marry me for three months? No, she would slap me for sure.

In honesty, Lloyd was already swamped with work at the Frontera fiefdom. The construction of the apartment complex and sewers was finalizing. He couldn’t think of an excuse as to why he was abandoning all those projects to visit Namaran. Just then...

Knock knock.

“Master Lloyd, are you inside?”

The knocking sound was followed by someone’s question. It was the administrator. Still lying on the sofa, he told him to come in.

“What brings you here?”

“Oh, I came to report to you the things you asked me a few days ago,” replied the administrator.

“Report? Oh, do you mean the statement of accounts for the workers?”

Lloyd rose up, recalling that he did assign the task.

“You’re done already?” asked Lloyd in surprise.

“Yes, the daily work log was very detailed, so it was a breeze. Here.”

But contrary to the administrator’s reassuring words, his eyes were dominated by dark circles. Feeling sorry, Lloyd took the wad of statements. He checked the total amount first.

“This is a lot more than I imagined...”

Lloyd felt bitter upon seeing the report. To tell the truth, the pay for the workers was considerably larger than he expected.

Well, it makes sense. It was a big construction that lasted for a long time.

In particular, the apartment complex construction started last year, and the construction of the sewers required the participation of the engineering corp, the White Cavalry, and regular workers. So, personnel expenses were expected to be high.

I’ll be stretching myself thin if I pay for everything at once.

The truth was, the financial situation in the fiefdom wasn’t enough. Lloyd was barely making it through with regular assistance from the royal palace and the water bill from Lacona viscounty. It was difficult enough to cover the expenses for the materials needed in all the various constructions. Just then, the administrator spoke in a careful voice.

“Um, young master, how about we pay them in parts instead of paying them all at once?”

“Hmm?”

“Since paying a large amount at once will burden the fiefdom. So, we ask for the workers’ consideration and give the payment until about the latter half of next year-”

“No.”

Not a chance. Lloyd shook his head right away.

“That’s not what I promised. The work contract didn’t mention anything like that in the first place.”

“But-”

“Stop. That’s enough. Contracts exist to be kept.”

Contracts were the same as promises in almost every way possible, and not keeping them would kill trust. No one would then roll up their sleeves and volunteer to work.

I’ve had enough of skipped and delayed payments in South Korea.

Lloyd experienced countless times in South Korea. His daily wage was often pushed back and given much later. Each time, he endlessly complained inside his head. And he wouldn’t repeat such a trashy practice just because the tables were turned for him in this world.

“Anyway, money is the problem.”

Lloyd let out a sigh after sending the administrator away. It couldn’t come at a worse time, as he was already preoccupied with the Namaran incident. Now, he had a financial concern on top of everything.

I need a new source of money.

Of course, he didn’t lack money. His fiefdom could live from hand to mouth if he tightened his belt. But it was time to break the status quo.

This isn’t good for my future as well. Everybody needs a pension to enjoy life as they get old, right?

The more, the merrier. Having more money was always good. It went the same right now. Though he had the palace and Lacona viscounty to fund his fiefdom, they weren’t guaranteed to help forever. The former might experience turmoil, while the latter could suddenly go bankrupt. If all his sources of income were cut off like so, Lloyd would struggle and die of hunger.

That won’t do.

Lloyd shook his head. For a more bountiful and beautiful life and to fulfill his promise to the workers, Lloyd had to earn more and acquire more funds.

The problem is how. It's not like money grows on trees. I *already have enough on my plate due to the Namaran situation. Haah. I wish there was a way to make money while preventing the Namaran Wall at the same time. Could there be a way to acquire a construction project in Namaran... Wait a minute.*

Lloyd sat upright as his grumbling turned into an epiphany. The answer turned out to be so obvious and simple.

"Wait a minute, I simply have to throw a pretext for a large construction project."

That would work. This would allow him to get paid for the construction and prevent the predicted disaster during the project. It was catching two birds with one stone and reaping double benefits at once.

So, what's the fitting construction for Namaran?

Lloyd searched for his memory, returning to the novel as much as possible. Small details started to come back to him. Namaran. The magical wall was built around there. Javier, struggling to break that. But he had a difficult time as the city was built on the edge of a high cliff similar to a pyramid. The slope was too steep, and the cliff sides crumbled so quickly. It was a much larger challenge than fighting on flatland.

That's it.

The side of the cliff crumbled easily, and the city sat at the very top. He thought about what problems that kind of terrain would cause the lord. As Lloyd put on his thinking cap, he started to see an answer.

Found it.

Before he knew it, Lloyd was out of bed. He passed the corridor and stairs, crossed the main building, headed to the annex building, and knocked on

Lady Namaran’s room.

“To what business do I owe you?”

One of the guard knights of the lady opened the door, and Lloyd immediately slipped his foot between the door like a salesperson who went from one house to another proclaiming he was selling an amazing product at a staggeringly generous price. He licked his lips and darted his gaze further in, behind the knight’s shoulder, toward the lady. And with the goal of saving everyone from disaster and making some money, he spoke.

“I don’t make this offer every day. I also don’t carelessly tell this to just anybody. The crumbling cliff and collapsing ground. They’re actually not much to worry about. Have you heard of the slope stabilization method that builds up crumbling cities and stabilizes collapsing cities?”

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Chapter 163: A City on a Cliff (1)

“Have you ever heard of the slope stabilization method?”

“Excuse me?” asked lady Namaran.

“I knew it,” said Lloyd with a wistful look. “You have not heard of such a great thing? There is nothing more unfortunate than that.”

“...”

With one leg on the door to stop it from closing, he used the signature tactic of salespeople in South Korea. Lloyd put on a plastic smile. Lady Namaran, upon seeing his smile, thought to herself whether he had lost his mind. But Lloyd didn’t care about what she thought. He simply got ready to fire his sales pitch.

“If you do not mind, may I enter and talk inside?” suggested Lloyd.

“What if I mind?”

“Then, we will converse just like this.”

“What if I do not wish to continue this conversation?” asked Lady Namaran.

“Then, you will be missing the perfect opportunity to solve the biggest conundrum your city faces,” said Lloyd confidently.

“You speak as though you can see through my hometown.” There was vague annoyance in her tone.

“Why wouldn’t I? Is there a law that forbids outsiders from knowing the problem with building a city on top of a cliff?” rebutted Lloyd.

“Of course, there is no such law.”

“Yes, you are right. And that is why...”

Thankfully, Lloyd was able to strike a conversation, and it was time to lay an attack. In a straightforward tone, Lloyd got to the heart of the matter.

“I will take care of your cliff problem.”

“You will?”

“Yes, I will.”

Lloyd shrugged. He was brimming with confidence to persuade her to trust and leave the matter to him.

“Your city is built on the cliff, but the foundation is weak. So, it is crumbling very slowly but surely, and in ten more years, the foundation of the city walls will be in danger of toppling. Am I correct?”

“...”

“Surely, Count Namaran must be striving hard, resorting to every means possible to find a solution. He probably tried planting trees on the cliff and plastering them with clay. But I would be surprised if it was effective at all.”

“You talk,” said Lady Namaran, “as though you can take care of it.”

“Because I can.”

“...”

“The slope stabilization method. With this method I mentioned, I can solve the problem. How about it, my lady?”

“What is this...”

Lady Namaran was surprised and at a loss for words. Truthfully, she was flustered by Lloyd’s abrupt appearance in her room and his aggressive and slightly hostile behavior and suggestion. These two factors were strange enough to make her doubtful of his intentions.

Who is this man?

She wondered if he was flirting with her. But she soon shook her head after a second.

It doesn't seem likely. He firmly put an end to the discussion of an arranged marriage earlier.

And more than anything else, he seemed too sincere for someone who was making a haphazard offer. His gaze and attitude were proof of it. To add to that, the queen had bestowed the title of mastery on this man.

I heard he built a bridge under the queen's order that makes you feel like you're walking in the sky. What's more, the people of Cremo admired him for his work in their city.

This man was the queen's favored engineer. Lloyd's name was well known all throughout the kingdom, so she was very familiar with his reputation. It seemed he could be trustworthy, maybe.

"Your suggestion, are you serious about it?"

She asked him as she remembered her hometown, Namaran, a city that was erected on a steep cliff similar to a pyramid. But it wasn't a big city from the beginning. About 400 years ago, Namaran was nothing but a small fortress built to watch over and supervise the trade route between the south and east.

However, the location was too perfect. Since it sat in an excellent location to watch over a major trade route, many merchants began to rest and unwind around the fort as it was safer than staying outside with mountain thieves, wild animals, and various monsters. Soon, inns started to appear in response to the group of resting merchants in the area, which also led to the construction of restaurants and multiple facilities. The fort grew in size as a result, expanding on and on. More people came rushing in, and the fort grew more vibrant. Once again, that led to another influx of merchants. There was even a trading post set up. From then on, Namaran was no longer

a rest stop for traveling merchants. It became a destination for trade. The city explosively developed until the current problem arose.

It was never meant to develop into a large city in the first place.

The fort was only meant to monitor trade. But it gradually grew larger to become a city, and the problem wasn't that the land on the cliff was narrow. It was that the city grew too big and expansive to the point that the cliff couldn't house it all. Making things worse, the soil on the cliff wasn't strong enough to bear the city's giant weight. That was when its slope started to crumble and fall apart, the process going on for decades. Slowly yet surely, the top of the cliff started to narrow.

That was where they were at now. The foundation of the wall was in danger of falling to pieces. Give a few more years, and the people's concern for the complete destruction of the wall could potentially come true. Lady Namaran waited for Lloyd to answer as she went over the situation in her head. Lloyd's answer was clear.

"Yes."

He could do it. He knew he could solve this problem. He said everything that needed to be said and tried to appeal to her as much as possible. It would be pointless to persuade or explain anything more. That would only make him look pathetic and clingy. As such, he pulled away, so the ball was in her court.

"Whether to trust me or not is your decision. So, please sleep on it."

Lloyd removed his leg from the door and retreated as though he never approached her in the first place. He flashed a nonchalant gaze. The choice was for her to make. He had nothing to lose. He smiled in a relaxed manner.

"I will take my leave now. Thank you for having me."

Without so much as a glance behind, Lloyd left.

"Wait, what-"

She wondered if this was what it feels to witness a passing storm. With the door left half ajar, her gaze was filled with daze as it stared at the door. The next day, Lloyd's strategy proved to be effective.

"I am thinking of leaving the construction to you," said Lady Namaran.

"Have you decided?"

"Yes."

Lady Namaran, who came to meet Lloyd the following day, nodded.

"I thought about it after you left."

The truth was that she didn't sleep a wink because of the issue. Lloyd couldn't be any more on point about the problem in Namaran. The confidence he manifested, and his reputation. She decided to trust him. It didn't sound like it would harm herself or her homeland, Namaran.

This might be the chance to impress my father.

Lady Namaran was actually forced to travel here by her family as they insisted on forming a good relationship with the eldest son of the Frontera family. They reminded her that this was the opportunity to solidify their family status. She recalled how her father escorted her with the evident expectation the day she left for this place. She felt pressured. She hated the idea of an arranged marriage. So she planned on returning home empty-handed, but at the same time, she felt apologetic. But not anymore.

I'm not going empty-handed at least. Though I'm taking him home not as my husband but as an excellent engineer.

Even though she wouldn't be satisfying her father's wish for marriage, she'd be able to make him happy by solving the ongoing issue of her city. That would be a good enough accomplishment.

"I am thinking about going with you on your return to Namaran. How does that sound?" suggested Lloyd.

“I welcome it, of course.”

Lloyd flashed a bright smile at her. Mission success. Now, all Lloyd had to do was fix the Namaran city, save the people there, and squeeze money out of them.

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The preparation for departure was simple. Prior to the day, he gave several instructions and notes about the apartment complex and sewage section construction to Sir Bayern. He entrusted the latter with the remainder of the project, and then bid farewell to the ladies in the manor. Afterward, the count and the countess sent him off on his path with Lady Namaran. Lloyd climbed mountains, traveled over the sea, and crossed a plain during his 12-day journey until he arrived at Namaran. The average altitude off the ground was 1,000 meters. And at the center of the high area, there stood a pyramid-shaped cliff.

“Ah... I’m craving a Drumstick cone...”

As soon as his eyes took in the city, he was reminded of his favorite ice cream in South Korea. The cliff that carried the city looked just like an upside-down ice cream cone. Javier, listening to him on the side, cocked his head to the side.

“What is a Drumstick cone”?

“Don’t worry about it. It’s a type of ice cream,” Lloyd said lazily.

“Do you mean the cold dessert that the royal family enjoys in the palace?”

“Yeah. Something like that.”

Lloyd nodded as he looked up at the cliff and the Namaran city at the top. The pyramid-shaped cliff reminded him of a melting Drumstick with cream spreading down the cone.

In other words, the cliff is a Drumstick cone melting upside down, and the city is one strawberry that was precariously placed on top.

The wall and the city looked exactly like what he just described. At the same time, Lloyd could easily figure out the reason behind its continual deterioration.

It's as I expected. Most of its foundation is made up of sandstone and slate.

Sandstone was a sedimentary rock that formed from compounded sand particles. Slate, the metamorphic rock, was a solidified form of shale after it was pressurized and heated. The two varieties couldn't be classified as hard rocks.

Yet, they built a city on such a foundation. No wonder the ground is unstable.

Lloyd climbed the cliff and looked around the ground using his survey skill. The way up was comparatively easy because the paved and wide road twirled around the cliff perimeter, allowing Lloyd to look in advance at almost all areas with his skill. So, he was able to naturally come up with a plan for what kind of work this city needed.

Retaining walls won't be enough in this case. No matter how much I build the walls on the outside to support the weight, it won't last long. It goes the same for Ggoming's spider web. I can cover up the cliff as much as I can, but it won't last.

This place was fairly sloped, and since the rocks were on the softer side, wrapping the outside would only be a band-aid solution. As such, the solution lay within.

I'll use piles and anchors. With it, I need to bind the surface and base foundation of the slate together. That way, I can properly support the pressure coming down from the crumbling sides of the slope and prevent a collapse.

The outline of his plan was formed in his head. Lloyd considered the necessary equipment, labor, time, and budget. He even thought about the construction process and timeline. He climbed to the top of the cliff as he came up with a broad idea in his head. But when he entered the castle gate,

a slightly peculiar scene caught his eyes. More than a hundred people were gathered in the plaza of the inner part of the castle. Most were raggedly clothed, and Lloyd caught a whiff of a nutty smell in the air. This scene seemed familiar.

That's...

“It is the meal center mister Cannavro runs.”

Lloyd didn’t realize that the window of the carriage was slightly opened. Inside, Lady Namaran was grinning.

“You did say the first time we met, right? How you came to respect mister Cannavaro after hearing his rumors,” she said, “Yes, that is right. That is the meal center he runs for free. Most of the people who fled from the east are in debt to his kindness.”

“I see...”

Lloyd studied the people in the center a little more. In contrast to their ragged clothing, everyone looked healthy and well, which must be due to good rest and diet.

But they must be ignorant of what his favor actually means.

Lloyd was scared for a second when he thought about how they’ll be sacrificed as an experiment. But completely oblivious to it, they were gathered around the center with happy smiles on their faces. Their eyes danced with gratitude as they looked at the one scooping up the food. Just then, Lady Namaran spoke.

“Oh, he’s just over there.”

“Excuse me?”

There? Who?

“Mister Cannavaro is there,” she said with a laugh. “Over there.”

"..."

Lloyd's gaze followed her finger outside the carriage window. The meal center. The focal point of people's gazes and smiles. A man holding a ladle with his sleeves rolled up. He was plump and looked meek. His warm smile toward the people thanking him could not be warmer.

"Do you see him? He is mister Cannavaro. Like always, he is taking good care of the refugees."

Lady Namaran's voice contained satisfaction and pride as though she was speaking of a city monument. But Lloyd could not agree with her. Was it because he knew what Cannavaro was? Or was it because he suddenly remembered that this man killed Lady Namaran in the novel? No. There was another reason why he clamped his mouth shut.

The grim reaper with a black dragon head.

There was a symbol embroidered on the shoulder of his clothing. At a glance, it looked like an ordinary family symbol. But Lloyd knew what it was.

The undead mastodons.

It was the symbol the necromancer that buried them used. Also, it was the symbol Queen Magentano selected in the novel after becoming a tyrant. And that sinister and ominous symbol was also on Cannavaro's clothes.

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Chapter 164: A City on a Cliff (2)

“You must be Lloyd Frontera. My, how unjust the rumors are as I behold you with my own eyes! Not a single rumor spoke of your dashing handsomeness. Hahaha!”

Here we go again...

Lloyd sighed lightly and lifted his gaze to find an older man striding across the flashy reception room of the manor. He was Count Namaran, whose appearance was likened to Santa Claus. The man walked over to them and tapped Javier’s shoulder with a look of satisfaction.

“I hope the journey here wasn’t too harsh,” the count said.

“It was not unbearable.” It was Javier who spoke.

“I see. Come over here and take a seat. Haha. How dashing you look. I can never get over it.”

The count’s smile deepened as he looked at Javier. The mere sight of the exchange forced Lloyd to put on a bitter smile.

Ha. What should I do? Correct him and say that I am the real Lloyd Frontera?

Lloyd shook his head.

No, I feel like that’ll make me even more miserable.

His nostrils flared twice, left and right each. Just then, to his relief, Lady Namaran stepped forward.

“Um, father?” she said.

“Hmm?”

“Actually, this man is...”

She pointed at Lloyd with a slightly flustered look, and it was only then that Count Namaran's gaze moved to Lloyd's side. He tilted his head to the side.

"Him?" the count asked, and with a look of realization, he then said, "Oh, oh! You must be the guard knight of Lloyd Frontera. The rumors told me that his guard knight, who is a sword master and goes by Javier Asrahan, looks like a sculpture crafted by the gods. And you... You definitely are not Sir Asrahan based on your looks."

The count then turned to Javier and continued.

"I suppose you did not bring Sir Asrahan with you this time. It was my wish to meet the kingdom's rising star and sword master. How unfortunate," the count clucked his tongue in regret.

The bitterness of life once again rushed through Lloyd, and Lady Namaran, this time terribly more flustered, spoke.

"Um, father. This is the young master. Lloyd Frontera." She then pointed at Lloyd Frontera awkwardly.

"Hmm?"

"This is Lloyd Frontera..." she murmured.

"..."

The count froze. Three seconds of silence followed in the room. His white beard jerked.

"This man?" the count gasped.

"Yes, father," Lady Namaran answered.

"This is Lloyd Frontera?"

"Yes, father."

"Then, who is he?"

“That is Sir Javier Asrahan,” she replied.

“The sword master?” asked the count again.

“Yes.”

“Ehem! Ehem! But, no matter how hard I look, that man looks nobler than him.”

“Oh, father...” she pleaded softly. “Even though we both cannot deny the fact that Sir Asrahan looks more opulent and noble than Lord Frontera, how could you say that out loud...”

Lloyd wanted to give up and go home immediately. His breathing grew heavy as he felt the wretchedness of lookism. But he needed to remain calm at times like these.

“It is an honor to meet you,” said Lloyd pretending to not hear what they just said. “My name is Lloyd Frontera.”

Lloyd introduced himself as the chance to present himself finally appeared. Count Namaran let out an embarrassed chuckle.

“My... Do excuse my impertinence.”

“It is fine, Your Excellency. I’ve had a similar experience before.”

“Is that so?” the count replied, “I knew it.”

I knew it, my ass!

Lloyd yelled internally, thinking about how the pair of father and daughter loved to verbally jab him. But strangely, Lloyd wasn’t offended. He felt rather sorry for the innocently smiling count as he remembered the scene he saw on his way here.

The count is completely oblivious to the fact that his city is entrenched with powers that aim to ruin this place.

Cannavaro. The man Lloyd met a while ago. The man behind the Namaran incident in the novel. On top of that, something else caught Lloyd by surprise.

I never imagined Cannavaro would use that symbol.

The grim reaper with a black dragon head. This symbol was found in the burial site of the undead Mastodons, and Lloyd presumed it was used by the necromancer responsible for it. Moreover, this symbol was used in *The Knight of Blood and Iron* after Queen Magentano started her terrorizing reign. And here was Cannavaro, using that symbol. What it entailed was crystal clear.

He has deep connections with the necromancer that buried the undead Mastodons near my fiefdom. Or he's the same person.

Something was brewing here, and it was serious. Lloyd considered that whatever this was, it was developing into something big. So he must delve into it someday. With that conclusion in mind, Lloyd lifted his gaze to focus on his business with Count Namaran. Then, putting a salesman smile on his face, Lloyd got ready to throw the eloquent pitch he had prepared.

"Count Naraman," Lloyd said, "it is my honor to be your acquaintance. Moreover, it is a greater honor for me to extend my hands to solve the long-standing problem that plagues your city."

"Hmm? What do you mean by that?" the count said.

Count Namaran cocked his head to the side, and he asked, "A long-standing problem? Tell me, you aren't talking about my daughter's inability to find a husband, are you?"

"No, Your Excellency. I mean the problem relating to the collapsing cliff."

"Cliff?" asked the count.

"Yes."

"But what about marriage?"

“Oh, that’s...” Lloyd murmured.

“Wait, are you here not to accept the marriage proposal but to repair the cliff of my city?”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

Lloyd realized that the count was misunderstood once more. Smoldering his wry smile, Lloyd spoke.

“Please forgive me for saying this, but your daughter is much too good for me. I am sure that she will meet someone better.”

“Ehem...” the count said, “But still, I cannot say that I am not disappointed.”

“I am sorry, Your Excellency. But if I may change your perspective, your daughter can get married later in the future, but that is not true for the cliff. Once it collapses further, it cannot be undone.”

“Is that so?” the count asked.

“Yes, Your Excellency. I think so.”

“What a silver tongue you have.”

“Thank you,” he said.

“And brazen.”

“Please forgive me,” Lloyd replied.

“So, you came here to fix the cliff that is crumbling at the moment?” the count summarized.

“That is perfectly correct.”

Thankfully, Count Namaran seemed to be a realistic man. From then onward, he never mentioned the matter of marriage; instead, he looked

grave and professional.

“I am well aware of your reputation as an engineer,” the count continued, “as I often heard of the rumors. That is, about your accomplishment in Cremo and the royal palace. But do know that I tried my best to solve the problem, calling renowned engineers across the kingdom. But they all failed. Yet, you are confident?”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

Lloyd didn’t feel the need to talk at length. He simply went on to speak what he wanted to say.

“You just need to provide the necessary funds and labor while I supervise the construction. But in the case that the construction fails or a serious defect is found, I will pay you a penalty fee that we agree upon in advance.”

“Penalty fee?” asked the count.

“Yes, Your Excellency. Will you look at this first?”

Lloyd fished a document out of his pocket. The count lifted his brow a little.

“What is this?”

“It is a construction contract.”

Lloyd had it made a day before leaving his fiefdom. He pointed to several points in the contact.

“As you can see,” Lloyd said, “Your Excellency will be entrusting me with the authority and responsibility of construction to me. I will be a supervisor that oversees and provides technical support in the process of surveying, designing, and constructing the project. In return, I will be paid a small fee after the construction ends successfully.”

“Hmm... The price is... considerable,” the count commented.

“No one can do it but me, after all.”

“And you are confident.”

“I say this is a rather inexpensive investment given that you will be stabilizing the city’s foundation for good.”

“But what is this item over here? Long-term maintenance fee?”

“Oh, that refers to the cost of maintaining the facility once the construction is over.”

“Does this mean I will pay you this fee every quarter?”

“Yes, Your Excellency,” replied Lloyd, “Continuous maintenance is a must even after a successful construction.”

“Hmm... This looks like...”

Count Namaran stroked his beard, gazing at Lloyd with suspicious eyes.

“Is this your scheme to squeeze money out of us over the years? You are quite a greedy man, aren’t you?”

“I am only receiving proper payment for my job. And that is also why the item regarding the penalty fee is included,” replied Lloyd.

“Yes, penalty,” mused the count. “I was curious about that. Let us see.”

Count Namaran read down the bottom of the contract with his gaze. Then, he nodded.

“I like this part,” he said.

“Do you, Your Excellency?”

“You will be paying thrice the construction fee if the project fails or a major fault is discovered. Are you sure this is doable?” asked the count.

“Yes, after all, it’s a contract.”

“Is that why you are writing this document?”

“This way, we can at least form some trust between us.”

Lloyd grinned. A contract was precisely that. It was the device that guaranteed minimal trust between the two parties. That was Lloyd’s take on contracts.

We’re turning our promises into permanent evidence. It’s more problematic if we don’t have a contract.

The one who got in trouble without it was the employees. Things turned against them, and there was a far, far higher chance for them to get harmed. Lloyd’s life in South Korea was proof of it.

When was it? Was it the time I had gone to Pohang for work?

Lloyd recalled the time he frequented the construction sites for work. One day, he received a call from a superintendent who used to favor him very much, saying that there was this two-week project in Pohang and that food and lodging would be provided. But he’d be working until late at night, and it would be lucrative. Lloyd gave a yes as soon as he heard it. And just like that, he headed to Pohang and got to work right after a safety education. But in the process, Lloyd committed a grave mistake.

I didn’t write a work contract. They told me that we can write it later after the project since everyone’s super busy at the moment.

Lloyd just let it slide, not thinking twice about it and fearing that his supervisors wouldn’t like his rigid attitude when it could be written at any time in the future. He hated the idea of standing out from the rest, so he agreed and got to work immediately. But that turned out to be a fatal mistake.

Eventually, my payments got delayed and delayed until I received only half of my money.

They said that payments would come the next day. The next month. They gave all sorts of pretenses that this wasn't what they wanted. There was an emotional exchange of excuses and yelling. Eventually, only the team managers and the supervisors who issued the payment bill as a re-subcontract agreement received the money, while the rest was left uncompensated. As a result, Lloyd went back to Seoul, emotionally and physically tattered. He financially struggled for the next month and laid low as he couldn't even pay his rent. That painful experience taught Lloyd one thing.

Contracts must be signed. Even if the sky collapses and the earth explodes.

That was how he could keep everything neat and organized after a project. Everyone, the contractor and service provider, stayed happy and peaceful when a contract was signed. Just like that, Count Namaran and Lloyd signed a contract.

"Thank you, Your Excellency," said Lloyd. "So, as per the contract, please prepare the funds, resources, and labor for the construction."

"How much should I prepare?" asked the count.

"I will come up with the plan and schedule soon. Once things materialize somewhat, I will let you know separately."

"Haha. You are a thorough man."

"I try my best."

Lloyd bowed courteously at the count and left the room. When he arrived at the visitors' quarter, where he would spend a while, he started unpacking and stared at Javier.

"Hey."

"Another job for me?" asked Javier.

"You have become quick-witted."

“I always have,” blurted Javier, who was bringing out his personal toothbrush, towel, and other items as he stood across from Lloyd. “Normally, you call me for one of two purposes.”

“What would those be?”

“To joke around or to give me a special order.”

“And you felt it was the latter this time?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.” Javier nodded. “Your left nostril isn’t flaring right now.”

“What?” asked Lloyd in disbelief.

Hold on, Lloyd said to himself as he wondered what this was about. He was in a daze when Javier replied back.

“Did you not know? You always flare your left nostril when you make a corny joke. Every time. Without fail.”

“...”

“When you do that, it reveals your nose hair very well,” added Javier.

“Y-you’re lying.”

“It does not matter whether you believe it or not. It is the truth.”

“...”

Lloyd suddenly felt lost, completely defeated by the sudden blow to his stomach. But since there was something more urgent to be dealt with first, he decided to play cool even though he was having a mental breakdown inside.

“All right. Let’s just say that you’re right. But do what I tell you to do first.”

“What job is it?” asked Javier.

“Do you remember Cannavaro? The guy at the soup kitchen in the plaza.”

“Yes,” said Javier, “Do you want me to do a background check on him?”

“How did you know?” asked Lloyd in surprise.

“I saw it too. The small symbol embroidered on his shoulder.”

“Then, I suppose I can save my explanation.”

“Of course. However...” paused Javier.

“But what?”

“In my honesty, I do not like the idea of looking into a man behind his back.”

Javier slightly furrowed his brows as he spoke.

“It does not befit my status or principles as a knight,” he said, “But I am simply following your order as I also think that the symbol is closely related to our fiefdom’s safety. Please do not forget this part.”

“So, you’re telling me that you are chary of doing this but feel the need to investigate that symbol, yeah?” asked Lloyd.

“That is right.”

“Then, off you go.”

“...”

Though Javier had expressed his distaste, he didn’t add anything.

“I will be back.”

Javier left the room after a sigh with a sword in his belt. Once he was gone, Lloyd went out to the city by himself, taking a closer look at the city walls and the foundation of the surrounding. That alone took up a whole day. At

last, when the night wore on, Javier returned to his room. It was past midnight with unfamiliar constellations adorning the night.

“Master Lloyd, I have something I must tell you.”

Seeing him, Lloyd wondered what could possibly Javier have seen in the last few hours that he should gaze at him so gravely. Javier, with a forbidding look on his face, spoke.

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Chapter 165: Undercover (1)

“Master Lloyd, a terrible accident has happened.”

“What?”

Javier spoke with a grim expression, and an old fluorescent light faintly shone behind his back. Lloyd rose up from a creaking bed.

“What’s going on?” Lloyd asked as he rubbed his sleepy eyes.

“It looks like we do not have enough to pay the rent for the rental room.”

“What...?”

What on earth is he saying? Lloyd asked, snappily coming to his senses. He looked up and found that he was in the room rental where he used to live back in Korea. Javier was standing against the wallpaper that had yellowed over the years. The sight was transcendental. Just then, Javier spoke, this time looking graver.

“Moreover, the news just reported that the convenience store will be raising the price of triangular gimbap to 100 dollars.”

“Hey,” huffed Lloyd, “What are you talking about?”

“I am not joking. It’s an official law. And the United Nations announced it as a grave matter. It’s set in stone now. Among them, the Jeonju bibimbap flavor, which is your favorite, will jump to 150 dollars.”

“Hey, man. Are you out of your mind? Hello?” said Lloyd as he waved his hands.

“I am sound in mind. It is all because of him.”

Javier pointed behind his shoulder with a serious look. Just then...

Clack. The old door opened, and a man dressed in black entered his tiny room. It was Cannavaro, the philanthropist Lloyd had seen this afternoon.

“Nice to meet you. I believe this is our first meeting. I am the new manager of this rental room,” introduced Cannavaro.

“Excuse me...?” Lloyd was dazed.

“I heard that you will be behind on rent this month. Please vacate this room right away.”

“Oh, what are you talking-”

“And your grades are not quite good enough to get a scholarship,” Cannavaro griped, “Wahaha!”

“Wh-what? Excuse me?”

What in the world was happening right now? Lloyd was at a loss and scared. He wanted to find out why on earth he was back in this tiny room again. And why were Javier and Cannavaro staring at him like that? But what about the things he went through? Frontera fiefdom? Lloyd Frontera? Chills ran down Lloyd’s spine.

N-No! Wait a second! No!

He shouted in a hurry, that this wasn’t making any sense, that it was unfair. But his emotional bawling, which was almost a plea, didn’t come out of his mouth. As if a terrible nightmare was playing with him, Lloyd could not utter any noise. He would have remained in that state if it weren’t for a hand that jerked his shoulder.

“Master Lloyd?”

“Eh... Argh!”

“Are you all right?”

“...!”

Lloyd opened his eyes, bolting upright in his bed. This time, the expensive bed didn’t creak. And the faint fluorescent light and yellow wallpapers were replaced with dancing lights and a luxurious interior. Amid the light, Lloyd spotted the knight of the blood and iron, Javier.

“J-Javier?”

“Yes, it’s me. Is everything okay?”

“I...”

“I fear you had a bad dream. A terrible nightmare was haunting you.”

“...”

Dammit. It was a bogus dream. A terrible one, even. Lloyd let out a sigh of relief. It was pretty nasty for a dream. But it was quite real. Lloyd was terrified as he thought about it. He shook his head sideways, shaking the fatigue and nightmare off his mind.

“Anyway, when did you get here?”

“I just arrived,” Javier said, “I have something to tell you.”

“This isn’t about whether the triangle gimbap got more expensive, right?”

“What is a triangle gimbap...?” Javier threw a weird look at Lloyd.

“That’s what you said in my dream.”

“Did I appear in your dream?”

“Uh-huh.”

“And that is why you had a nightmare?”

“Uh-huh.”

“...”

“Anyway, so what did you need to tell me?”

“It pertains to Cannavaro,” Javier replied.

“Something suspicious?”

“Please see for yourself…”

Javier unpacked the bundle he was carrying on his shoulder. It contained four pieces of clothing. One coat that was considerably thick. Three comfy inner shirts. Each had a different color and shape, but there was one commonality. It was...

“Dragon head grim reaper embroidery. Where did you find them? Did you steal them from his house?” asked Lloyd.

“Not at all.” Javier shook his head. “I bought it at the market.”

“What?” Lloyd said, his brows quirking up, wondering what he was hearing.

“Since I went out this afternoon,” Javier continued, “I began the background check at the soup kitchen as per your instructions and looked into his manor. I dressed like a normal merchant and studied his behavior.”

“Did you hide your face?”

“Yes, somewhat.”

“So?”

“Several parts of his manor were protected by magical devices that prevented entry, just like any other rich man. But I did manage to roughly look around the rest of the estate. And I was able to continuously study his movements in the process. But...”

“But what?” hurried Lloyd.

“I did not detect any suspicious behavior in my hours of studying him. No, it was the contrary.”

“Contrary?” asked Lloyd, and Javier wore an expression that Lloyd found incomprehensible.

“His actions were filled with goodness and kindness. To the point that I wondered if he was not the most generous person I have ever met.”

“But you just saw him for a few hours,” Lloyd pointed out.

“Surely, the hours aren’t much, but he... he nursed the patients in his manor after his work in the soup kitchen. Sick patients whose entire bodies were wasting away.”

“So?”

“He was carefully wiping down the pus spilling out of a patient’s body for hours. He never frowned once.”

Javier expounded the sight one after another, saying how clear it was in his eyes. What Cannavaro did went beyond normal human capacity. Who would, Javier had asked himself, do such a thing to a total stranger in this world? And who could put on a gentle smile without any expression of tiredness?

“He moved me,” Javier said with conviction.“That was when I felt regretful. Here I was sneaking behind him, doing a background check when he owns such an exemplary character. That is when I found it.”

“Found what?” asked Lloyd.

“There were patients in his care that wore these clothes.”

“So?”

“I struck a conversation as I changed a patient’s bandage, pretending to be one of the volunteers,” he explained, “as the conversation progressed, I

threw out that the embroidery on his clothes looked interesting. The patient told me that I could buy it at the market."

"Market?"

"That is right."

Javier's gaze moved over to the clothes. "It was true. Some merchants were selling them."

"And you bought all of them?" asked Lloyd.

"No, just a portion of it. I saw dozens more at the market. That was how common the symbol was," concluded Javier.

"Whew."

Lloyd sighed at length. The print turned out to be so common that it was sold at a market. This changed things. Lloyd racked his brain as he furrowed his brows.

The dragon head grim reaper was commercialized? That's unexpected. But still, Cannavaro is surely the head of the dark magicians.

That was the case in the novel, and he surely had to be the leader. As such, Lloyd could not retreat like this. The investigation had to go on.

There's no guarantee that he'll move and do things exactly as in the novel. The chances are likely that he'll behave differently. I might find myself in hot water if I only base my plan on what happened in the novel.

Knowledge of an enemy ensured unfailing victory. So, Lloyd decided to be more alert and vigilant in monitoring Cannavaro. Every piece of information, even small and trivial, like the number of forks in his house and the color of his underwear, had to be tracked until something suspicious came up. Once Lloyd chanced upon the smoking gun to prove Cannavaro's evil scheme, he would report it to Count Namaran and have the man arrested. With such a plan in his head, Lloyd spoke.

“You’re not telling me you want to stop following him around, are you?” asked Lloyd.

“Surely...”

“Don’t stop here. Keep going.”

“But Master Lloyd.”

“I have a bad feeling about this one. Something is definitely going on here,” Lloyd insisted.

“...”

“Can’t you trust me?” asked Lloyd as he stared at Javier.

“I don’t.”

“Your responses are unusually fast during times like these.”

“You are mistaken.”

“I don’t think so.”

“...”

“Do trust me a little,” said Lloyd. “I get that you are reluctant to check on him behind his back, but we are just playing it safe.”

“Playing it safe?”

“Yeah. It’s not like me being right about this matter will hurt our fiefdom.”

It was true. If Lloyd was right about this, the Namaran incident would be prevented, and it could lead to discovering a future threat to his fiefdom.

“So, it’s an order. Keep digging for more information,” ordered Lloyd.

“Normally,” Javier replied, “People try to pull at their listener’s heartstrings instead of placing an order in this kind of situation.”

“Why should I do that?”

“...”

“Why try persuading or making a request when ordering works better?”

“...”

“I say jump, and you say how high,” said Lloyd nonchalantly.

“Whew. I shouldn’t have woken you up earlier.”

“Why,” asked Lloyd, “so I’ll suffer from my nightmare?”

“You know it.” Javier clucked his tongue as he got up. “I will take my leave then.”

Javier was already gone like the wind before he was done speaking. The only traces of his visit was a candlestick, opened window, and a swaying curtain. Lloyd was astonished by his speed.

Sword masters are truly amazing.

Lloyd was already a mid-level sword expert, but he couldn’t sense Javier’s movement at all. He didn’t notice that the latter left until he was gone. And that was the reason why Lloyd was relieved. There was nothing to worry about him spying on the man.

Time to focus on my job while he’s gone.

Closing the opened window, Lloyd sat at the desk and decided to leave the matter pertaining to the dark magician in Javier’s hands. Meanwhile, he would get ready for the construction project. He opened the design skill thinking so.

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A few days passed, and Lloyd was able to flesh out his construction project.

It's as I had thought before. I should use piles and anchors.

Since the city was supported by the sandstone slope, solidifying the facade wasn't enough. There needed to be piles and anchors inserted deep into the slope to create a firm, steadfast foundation. But there was one problem.

I need to manufacture anchors.

The anchors were to be planted into the foundation rocks after countless holes were bored into the cliff slope. However, this job involved more than sticking metal bars inside. Moreover, logs and bamboo sticks weren't enough. To succeed, Lloyd needed a modern version of anchors.

That's how I can fasten the anchors inside the holes bore in the slope. The force from the foundation rock to the facade will prevent the cliff from crumbling down. But to do that, the anchors have to be properly fastened first.

And so, once he was almost finished with the design, he visited Count Namaran.

"Please introduce me to the most competent blacksmith in the city," Lloyd said.

"A blacksmith?"

"That is right."

Lloyd unraveled his general outline for the construction and anchors. In particular, he showed the blueprint to the count, as he explained his plans for the anchors.

"This construction requires this object," Lloyd explained, "And to do that, I need the help of a competent blacksmith."

"To make these anchors?" asked Count Namaran.

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

Actually, this anchor Lloyd designed was closer to the “wedge lock bolt” used in South Korean construction fields. The basic principle went like this…

A large nut will be attached to the end of a long cylindrical bar. I’m going to push the bar deep into a hole that is burrowed as far as the foundation rock. And once I twist the nut at the end, the bar will expand once it penetrates inside, and as it does so, the bar will be completely fixed inside the hole.

It was a magical stick that thickened as the nut rotated.

Anyway, I need to carve spiral grooves into the nut to make that structure.

The spiral grooves would function as a bolt. Only the best and most competent blacksmiths would be capable of creating them to their exact size.

It’s not like I can call Corgidus here.

Corgidus was most likely pounding down on the metals that would be used in the apartment complex today. Lloyd couldn’t make the busy man come all the way here.

“So,” Lloyd said, “I need the best blacksmith in the city. We can’t properly carry out the construction otherwise. And without the construction, the cliff will collapse. If the cliff collapses, you will be very sad. If you become very sad, I will be very sad as well.”

“Haha, really?”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“I expect it will be an amusing sight.”

“And that means...”

“Of course, I shall introduce you to the best blacksmith in my city.”

“Thank you,” Lloyd said.

“No need to thank me since we signed the contract. I will have the administrator get to work, so follow him.”

Lloyd stepped out of the office, hearing the count’s laughter, and the administrator appeared as he waited in the corridor. Lloyd was then led out of the manor through the city district, passing by countless ordinary citizens under the early autumn sun. As he did so, he paid close attention to his surrounding.

Every piece of evidence counts.

Lloyd wondered if Javier was doing a good job. It had been days since he left his room. Lloyd was passing the plaza with the administrator, wondering if Javier was doing a good job when he spotted something extraordinary.

“Whew. I see the rumors are true. There are too many people crowding the soup kitchen.”

The administrator, who was walking ahead, paused and spoke. Surely, there were more people around the soup kitchen than before. Curious, Lloyd stopped as well.

“Is it because the number of refugees has increased?” asked Lloyd.

“Oh, that is not the case I heard.”

“Then, what is it?”

“I heard that a beautiful lady started volunteering in the past few days.”

“A beautiful lady...?”

Lloyd tilted his head, and his reaction invited a more passionate and joyful response from the administrator.

“Honestly,” he started, almost spitting, “I have not seen her with my own eyes. But the rumors tell me she is breathtaking. One of a kind. I heard her beauty is so pristine that even the stars and constellations are jealous of her. Ha... That is likely the reason why so many people, who are not refugees, have been flocking to the kitchen.”

“To take a look at this beautiful lady?” asked Lloyd.

“Why else?”

The administrator shrugged, and then, he stole a glance at Lloyd as though he was testing the latter.

“Speaking of, how about we stop for a moment and take a look at her? That is if you are not too busy...”

“...”

Lloyd paused for a moment to decide what he should do. He was curious as well, but not because he wanted to take a look at this ravishing beauty the administrator just described.

I might come across a clue that’s related to the dark magicians.

The appearance of a belle when the Namaran incident will take place soon? This wasn’t in *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* Something didn’t seem right. Lloyd nodded.

“Good,” Lloyd said, “Let us go take a look.”

The administrator grinned ear to ear, and the two squeezed their way into the crowd. They shoved, squeezed, and wiggled inside the crowd to get some space, making Lloyd recall the times he had to fight his way through the train station to find a seat during rush hour. Finally, after some struggle, they managed to get in, and the soup kitchen appeared in their sight. Everyone’s gaze focused on one point. And there, he saw beauty. Though she wore a modest apron, her eyes glimmered like dazzling stars, and her

straight silver hair flowing down looked like a constellation. And this belle, this enchantress with a ladle in her hand was...

Javier?

Lloyd, who was rubbing his eyes, almost poked his eyes with his finger at the sight.

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Chapter 166: Undercover (2)

Javier?

Lloyd was rubbing his eyes, and he almost poked his eyes with his finger. It was the only rightful response. The sight was that dismaying.

And he tells me what? That he hates digging up someone's background? He feels resentful because this job is below him?

Lloyd recalled the conversation that took place a few days ago. The moon was bright that night, and Javier returned to the lodging with a face overwhelmed with guilt and resignation. He had opposed Lloyd's order to do a background check on Cannavaro. Lloyd had to soothe and persuade him to put him back on the scene. And it had been a few days since Lloyd heard from him. Now he knew why.

You were actually enjoying this, Javier...

Modest dress. Silky and straight silver wig. Light makeup. Lloyd sighed and let out praise at the same time. Since he was already a handsome, gentle, and noble man, a simple disguise was enough to turn him into a stunner.

Not to mention, he's slim and muscular with little body fat. And so, Javier looks very fit when he's dressed. Though he's a bit too tall, I suppose he just looks like a supermodel to others.

Anyway, his appearance brought raving popularity throughout the kitchen. Lloyd wondered for a second if he was at a meet-and-greet for a famous celebrity. Just then...

"Hey, mister."

Someone tapped Lloyd on the shoulder from behind. He turned and found a refugee man shooting a nasty look at him.

“Seriously, if you’re in line, move faster,” demanded the man. “Why are you so slow?”

“Oh?” said Lloyd, dazed.

“Stop dazing out, move now. Come on.”

“Eh!”

The man began to shove Lloyd with his whole body, but it wasn’t just him. Dozens of people from behind moved forward with their whole weight pushing up the line, and the experience strangely felt familiar.

It’s like I’m on the second line at the train station in the morning

Lloyd was reminded of the Shindorim station during rush hour. It was far from a normal train station. All sorts of people pushed and shoved through each other, turning the platform into a battlefield, and it was also a mysterious place where movement didn’t require the exercise of two feet. The others did it for you as they pushed their way forward. That event was taking place right now to Lloyd in this world, who had scooted his way to take a look at Javier. And by some random turn of events, he found himself in the line for rations, and it was too late to slip out. Now stuck in the queue, Lloyd was moving forward as people became intimate with each other toward Javier, the goddess of the soup kitchen.

“...”

“...”

Javier blinked as he stared at Lloyd. The latter smiled nastily at the former. The silence was short-lived, however, for Javier put on his character and played his role.

“Your plate, please.”

“Oh.”

Lloyd picked up the wooden plate by reflex and held it to him. And Lloyd involuntarily asked a question to Javier.

“Excuse me, but what is your name, my lady?” asked Lloyd.

“Oh... It’s Ella.”

“Ella?”

“Yes. E-l-l-a. Ella.”

“...”

Lloyd figured that Javier was flustered just as much, given his unusually dazed response.

This bastard.

Lloyd knew Javier went undercover in this kitchen to learn more about this place. So, he left to ensure he wouldn’t make things more awkward for Javier.

“Thank you, Miss Ella. So long.”

He took the soup and chugged it in one gulp and removed himself from the scene, though it also required some struggle. Now freed, he was collecting his breath when the administrator approached him.

“Haha, Lord Frontera, I did not peg you to be a man of such character.”

“Excuse me?”

Lloyd tilted his head to the side, wondering what this man was talking about and his smile. The administrator flashed a grin that wrinkled his nose as though he was telling Lloyd to stop playing dumb.

“When I told you about this beautiful lady,” he said, “you seemed barely interested. But now, you are more forward than I am after you caught sight of her.”

“…”

“What was it like talking to her directly? What was her voice like? And her manner of speech?” the administrator urged.

“Goodness, check for yourself if you’re curious. Let’s get to work, ahem!” huffed Lloyd.

Lloyd gulped as he pretended to huff at the administrator. His mouth was itching to break the shocking news to everyone. All of you’re being deceived. Miss Ella is actually a man who’s far from being gentle and lovely. Furthermore, he’s incapable of falling asleep without a lullaby because of his terrible sleeping habit. If Lloyd could do it, he wanted to spread this news to all corners of the city as he felt sorry for the people who worshiped Ella, not knowing her real identity. But Lloyd decided to stay silent for a greater cause.

Javier is undercover right now.

Javier wasn’t the type to make jokes like this, and there had to be a reason behind his actions. There had to be something fishy going on to explain how far he was going with his disguise.

I should trust him for now.

Lloyd decided to leave him be and walked away. Now that he saw that Javier was working hard to fulfill his order, Lloyd thought he should do his part too. So, he went to the blacksmith at the administrator’s guidance and requested the anchor bolts. The blacksmith cocked his head at first, which was a natural response given the unfamiliarity of the anchor itself. But when Lloyd expounded the item with the help of his blueprint, the blacksmith finally nodded in understanding.

It’s a relief. Since he’s the most reliable blacksmith in the city, I can entrust him with the anchors. Though he won’t be as great as Sir Corgidus.

That was one less burden off him. Next, Lloyd went out of the castle alone and walked along the cliff slopes that surrounded the castle. He then

activated the Subterranean Scanning, an optional skill of his surveying.

Since I have to plant the piles and anchor bolts around here, I should survey this place more thoroughly.

Lloyd looked closely at the construction area, particularly the location of the piles and the angle and depth of the anchor bolts.

Hmm, I should plant the piles in these flat roads and increase the overall structural stability. And I should install the anchor bolts in the slopes to prevent any slippage. Repeat this process from the upper area in the castle wall, to the lower part of the cliff, and that should do it.

With such a plan in his head, Lloyd obtained the data of the terrain, sweeping through every corner of the foundation rock and collecting every detail. As he did so...

Hmm?

He was looking into the ground with his optional skill when he detected something strange down there.

What is that?

About 20 inches under the ground, Lloyd found something that at first glance thought was a rock. But it wasn’t. The upper part was white and round while the lower part was rugged.

Is that a skull? What’s it doing here?

Lloyd frowned. It really was a human skull buried underground. But no matter how much he looked at it, this place hardly looked like a suitable area for a grave. Not to mention, there was only a skull here and no other bones.

Could it be that those who were beheaded have been buried down here?

Lloyd shrugged nonchalantly. After all, he was around a large, historical city. All sorts of things must have happened throughout the years. There

was no reason to fuss about a skull as it could be the result of execution. Thinking so, Lloyd ignored it and resumed focusing on his work. He activated the optional skill and moved around until, sometime later, he discovered another skull.

What the?

Lloyd frowned. It was very similar to the previous one. Similarly, a skull without a body was buried about 20 inches deep in the ground. This time again, Lloyd brushed the thought away, simply cocking his head to the side.

This doesn't feel good. Or is my luck just off today? If I were in Korea, I'd have bought lottery tickets.

He scoffed at the sudden thought, which allowed him to dismiss the bad feeling away. He then got back to work again. Ten minutes later, however, the smile on his face was completely gone.

What the heck? Another one?

Once again, there was another skull buried in the same depth. However, this time Lloyd found that upon a closer look that the skull was buried upright, facing the city, just like the previous ones.

"..."

Lloyd stared behind him with a serious look and observed the points where he first found the two skulls. As he used his surveying skill, he shockingly noticed there was an even distance between each skull.

Something's going on here.

Now, his previous theory of skulls being buried as the result of execution proved to be false. Plus, the three skulls faced the same direction in the same depth. Not to mention, the interval between them was almost all the same. The difference was only about five inches.

It looks like someone used a ruler to bury them. So, *it wasn't buried here randomly or by chance. Something's really going on right now.*

Lloyd hurriedly raked through his bag and fished a foldable pickax. He then dug the area with a lot of effort until he excavated the skull. He stretched out his hand to pick it up.

Bzzt!

“Argh!”

An electric shock hurt his fingers. Lloyd quickly withdrew and observed the skull.

Magic?

Lloyd didn’t feel any magical force when it was under the earth. But now that it was out in the open, he could feel it. And the Asrahan Core Technique allowed him to discover that the mana, which was extremely gloomy, dark, and evil, was highly concentrated in the skull.

Wait a minute. Could this be...

Lloyd started to rack his brain. Skulls are buried in regular intervals. A high concentration of gloomy mana. Lloyd theorized, predicted, and considered the facts at hand without anything amiss. The evidence and phenomenon that appeared before him were put to inference and estimation. At last, as the small pieces of puzzles were put together, Lloyd slowly reached a conclusion.

These were used to make Namaran’s Wall.

Chills ran down his spine at the realization. He recalled the scene with Namaran’s Wall in the novel, where Javier experienced dramatic growth after a series of suffering and despair. The story only focused on his heroic feat, not on the mechanics behind the wall.

Yes. This is it. Skulls with black magic. They were buried around the city’s perimeter.

Lloyd stared at the skulls and thought that he could eliminate the dark magic in them if he could dissipate the mana. And he’d be able to prevent

the erection of the Namaran’s Wall.

Let’s give it a try.

Lloyd observed the amount of mana concentrated in the skull, and he inspected the Asrahan Core Technique.

Triple Circle level two.

Would mobilizing everything here allow him to discard the concentrated mana inside? Lloyd searched for an objective answer.

I can do it.

He found his answer. And so, there was no need to hesitate.

Ziiing! No one was looking at him just in time, so he activated the Asrahan Core Technique and turned the mana absorption skill to the max. When the tips of his fingers touched the skull...

Hmph.

Exceedingly depressive mana flooded into him like a tsunami.

I can’t eat this. I’ll get sick.

He rotated the three-stranded circle as much as he could, sending the depressing mana flowing into this body to the other side of his hand. The process was delicate and thorough, like untangling a ball of yarn. The mana was sent out into the air little by little. A few minutes later...

“Whoa!”

Lloyd sighed heavily, and though his face turned slightly pale, he wore a satisfying smile on his face.

I did it.

Lloyd wondered if this was what it felt like to be part of the EOD. Thankfully, the three circles held up very well in absorbing and discharging the mana. Now, the gloomy mana, heavily concentrated in the skull, was completely gone. He picked it up to get a closer look.

Clack. Just then, there was a jingling sound inside the skull. He heard something small and hard rolling around.

“Huh?”

Lloyd’s eyes widened when he looked at the inside.

“A jewel?”

Lloyd found a jewel, which looked like an obsidian, placed inside. It was the size of a thumbnail. With one look, Lloyd noticed its glossiness. The jewel looked super expensive.

Hold on. So, the skulls were just a box that held the jewels, and the jewels were what held the concentrated mana. Okay, so since this jewel is normal now that I washed the mana away... Thank you. It’s mine now.

Grin. A capitalistic, avaricious smile appeared on Lloyd’s face, and his heart started to pound at great speed. From then on...

Time for a treasure hunt!

Lloyd’s feet profusely sweated as he ran around the cliff slopes, like a puppy panting as it searched for a bone or a child fishing for bacon in a bacon salad. His eyes reddened as he searched the ground. To resist the evil plan of the dark magicians, to send a stunning gift to his enemies, and to pocket some expensive jewels and fatten his wallets, Lloyd gave everything to this greedy race in the name of justice.

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Chapter 167: Undercover (3)

There was a common saying that said, “money doesn’t grow on trees”. It meant money wasn’t something that was freely found. Normally, that was true. You didn’t often find money just lying anywhere on the ground. However, Lloyd’s current situation was a bit different.

Money doesn’t grow on trees? That’s right. It comes from the ground!

Lloyd’s content gaze moved toward the hole he had just bored. About 20 inches deep down, there was a skull. A real one, not the kind used in biology class at school. Any normal person would have shuddered at the sight, but not Lloyd. He was different.

Whew. My precious.

His gaze, which was stuck to the skull, resembled that of a greedy man looking at his golden goose. Or that of a passerby who spotted a 50 dollar bill amid a pile of leaves in the fall. However, this was hardly surprising as the skull contained a precious jewel.

So, in other words, I simply have to clear the concentrated mana, and the jewel will be mine. Like this or that way.

Ziiing! Lloyd rotated his three-strand mana circles with the dream of being filthy rich, sucking the mana pressured in the jewel. The rotation disintegrated the mana structure, and the process was likened to getting rid of the fuse in a time bomb and pulling out a Zenga block from a delicately put pile. He disintegrated and disassembled the mana structure. Then, he moved it to the other side of his arm.

Psssh... The mana, which became innocuous now, dissipated and spread throughout the air. Sometime later, around the time sweat started to drip from his forehead, the dangerous energy loaded in the jewel finally disappeared. A rewarding smile appeared on his face.

Now the jewel is mine. Mwahaha.

Clack! The jewel rolled out of the skull and landed on his palm. How pretty and wonderful it was to behold. He studied the jewel and all its dimensions. Mirth danced in his eyes.

Nice. There isn't even a single blemish. It's perfect.

This was the 24th one. Lloyd had been roaming around Naraman's wall for several hours now, and he discovered 24 skulls and just as many jewels. His bloating pocket pleased him. But it came with a tad bit of guilt.

"I do not know what terrible thing you went through, but may you rest in peace."

After taking the stone, he placed the skull on the ground, giving it a respectful bow. And he set the skull into the sack with care lest he damages it. Three more sacks lay around him, containing all the 24 skulls he had found.

It's a relief that there were clothes in my bag to turn into sacks.

Otherwise, he wouldn't have thought of carrying these many skulls.

Although I can't hold a funeral for them, I should at least bury them in good soil.

These victims were buried without anything else but their skull. And worse, they were abused by no other than dark magicians. So, it went without saying how resentful their souls must be after they were half-heartedly buried in this cold earth with an evil stone planted in their skulls. Lloyd hated to leave them here. Though the job was slightly bothersome and laborious, it was the proper thing to do. The least he could do was give them a proper burial in fertile land. And so, Lloyd made sure to take the skulls along with the stones, so engrossed in the process that the sun was already hanging on the west horizon before he knew it. The night would come soon, and his surroundings would grow dark.

Should I return to the lodging first?

Lloyd took the skull-loaded sacks and placed them in his lodging. And he once again stepped out. This time, he had more sacks with him.

Duh. Why should I stop this treasure hunt just because it's dark?

The hay must be made when the sun shines. The mast must be raised when the wind is good. The same went for keeping the treasures in the ground. Lloyd had to take this chance and abuse it, much like going to a buffet with the intent of expanding your stomach or taking the chance to progress your situationship with your crush after they confessed. As the opportunity presented itself to Lloyd, he had to sweep the entire area for hidden gems, even if it meant pulling an all-nighter.

This opportunity won't last long.

Since the job involved sneaking around and stealing the stones containing dark magicians' magic, it was only a matter of time before they noticed the disappearance of the magic circle they had painstakingly crafted.

I have to take as many as possible before they notice anything. I can do it.

Lloyd rushed out of the castle, so speedily that the callous in his feet started to sweat. It was as though he was darting to a store after it announced a one-day mega sale and giveaway event. He dug, dug, dug, and dug, his every scoop reflecting the heart of a farmer harvesting a bumper crop and a fisher pulling up a net of riches. As a result, Lloyd discovered countless skulls, dissipated the mana in them, and pocketed the jewels. He also earned an unexpected reward in the process.

Ding Dong!

[Skill Level Up!]

[The Asrahan Core Technique: Triple Circle Lv. 3]

[Mana amplified to: 560%]

[Skill Options: ① Energizer / ② Latent Power Surge / ③ Power Saving Mode / ④ Circle Shift / ⑤ Supercharge]

[Required RP to level up: 600]

[Current RP: 3,005]

Yes!

Checking the message in front of his eyes, Lloyd clenched his muddy fists. He had been using the Asrahan Core Technique to its maximum capacity as he removed the evil mana in the stones. The job itself turned out to be a great source of training for his skill.

Oh, I made the right choice by coming to Namaran.

Lloyd now desisted from the dark magicians, obtained a boatload of expensive jewels, leveled up his Asrahan Core Technique, and thoroughly checked the construction site for the slope stabilization method. Lloyd, who could utilize the Subterranean Scanning and the Asrahan Core Technique, was the only one able to do all this work at once.

Lalalala! Yes, yes!

He started to hum subconsciously. The humming became his companion and stayed with him all throughout the night he mined the jewels.

***

“Did something happen to you?”

The next day, around midnight, Lloyd was smugly smiling as he counted the jewels he had scavenged the previous night in his lodging when he heard a familiar voice out the window. It was quite icy. Lloyd turned and found Javier slipping into the window.

Cocking his head, Lloyd asked, “By the way, what tremendous event led to you becoming a flashy lady?”

Javier was making his way through the window in the exact countenance Lloyd had seen the previous day in the soup kitchen. Modest and humble dress. Silky silver hair. He was Lady Ella at the moment. Javier was embarrassed to be in such a fashion, so he wrinkled his nose and spoke.

“I had no choice,” blurted Javier.

“You had no choice? Did you run out of clean clothes to wear?”

“Your response is terribly incorrect and offensive. That is definitely not it,” defied Javier.

“Then?”

“Like I told you, there were areas in Cannavaro’s house that were off-limits.”

“You mean the areas protected by magic?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, the basement.”

“Did you disguise as a woman to peep at the place?”

“Yes,” Javier said as he nodded. “I had no other choice even though I am a sword master. The magical protection can’t be penetrated. So, this was the only way for me to make my way there without being caught.”

Javier frowned slightly, and Lloyd wondered what he was thinking about.

“At first, I didn’t mean to cross-dress. But my face was the problem.”

“Because you’re too handsome?” joked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“What. Are you seriously saying that?”

“It is the undeniable truth.” Javier sounded like he was talking about something very obvious. “I was too conspicuous. I could disguise myself,

but my face can’t be altered. So, I thought outside the box.”

“Which was dressing as a woman? Because even if you draw attention, nobody will guess it’s you?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, they will never think even for a second that a renowned knight would put on a woman’s disguise. That’s what I thought and why I did it.”

Javier slightly lifted his front skirt with his hands.

“I was worried a little at first, but no one doubted me.”

“And you are now the ravishing beauty in the city, Lady Ella.”

“Please erase that from your memory...” Javier chuckled, shuddering at the thought. “Anyway, thanks to my disguise, I was able to enter the basement on the fourth day on account of running an errand. But I found the place to be slightly off.”

“In what way?”

“There was another basement in the basement.”

“My, my. Were you able to get in there?” asked Lloyd.

“Not yet. It looked like only the closest cohorts of Cannavaro could enter inside.”

“I see,” said Lloyd, “this is very fishy.”

“Are you still doubting him?”

“Of course.”

Lloyd looked at him, his head cocked in a haughty manner.

“Do you still consider him to be a good man?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes,” said Javier confidently.

“How so?”

“I have not found anything that ties him to be an evil man,” Javier answered. “And he is still spending every minute of his day taking good care of the refugees.”

“Tsk,” said Lloyd, “You’re saying this even after you saw the basement situation?”

“It could be a secret vault, which is common among wealthy families.”

“Then,” Lloyd argued, “why did you disguise as a woman if you plan on defending him?”

“I would like to remind you once again that this is all to fulfill your order to the utmost capacity.”

“That’s a good answer,” Lloyd said sarcastically.

“I learned from you, Master Lloyd.”

“You are brazen.”

“Thank you very much,” answered Javier.

Javier then smiled faintly before asking Lloyd a question.

“By the way, I asked you a while ago, but did something happen to you as well?”

“Hmm? Why?” said Lloyd quizzically.

“The dark circles around your eyes deepened. But strangely, your expression is brighter.”

“Does it show?”

“Yes, very much.”

“Haah. Actually, I discovered these.”

Lloyd brought out one black stone and showed it to him, explaining everything that had taken place the night before. How he had come across a skull in the ground while surveying. How it was concentrated with mana. How removing the mana in the skull made a jewel appear. An incomprehensible expression appeared on Javier’s face after he heard the story.

“So you stole, no, excavated these jewels all night long?” asked Javier.

“Yeah. And I think the skull and the stone have something to do with Cannavaro.”

“Do you have proof?”

“That’s your job to find out from now on,” Lloyd said.

Of course, he didn’t have any evidence yet. There wasn’t a single piece of evidence to prove that Cannavaro was behind the skulls and jewels. However, Lloyd knew.

This is his doing. I’m completely sure.

Lloyd was sure because he had read the novel. Cannavaro was the man responsible for the incident with Namaran’s Wall. And a similar thing was to take place in this world.

“So, I’m telling you,” stated Lloyd. “You said that there is another basement underneath, right? Look into it. There’s got to be something in there.”

“Master Lloyd,” called Javier suggestively. “Did it ever cross your mind that you may be falsely accusing Lord Cannavaro?”

“Yeah, so you’ll have to check if my conviction is wrong or not, right?” asked Lloyd.

“...”

“Moreover, if this jewel really belongs to Cannavaro, something about him will change tomorrow. After all, he’ll think the jewels were stolen. He’ll act differently, or his people will be busy. Try to take advantage of that moment.”

“...”

“What, want to make a bet or something?” joked Lloyd.

“What kind of bet?” asked Javier in a serious tone.

“If I thought wrong and Cannavaro has nothing to do with this, I’ll call you ‘Master’ for a year. That is when no one else is around,” suggested Lloyd.

“Make it three years. How does that sound?”

“What?!”

“Are you scared?” smirked Javier.

“No, not at all. But in case I’m right, you will wear this costume when we return to Frontera county.”

“...”

“Scared?” asked Lloyd.

“No, not at all.”

“Good. But we have to be honest in front of the truth that will be revealed. Got it?”

“Of course. After all, this bet is just for fun.”

That went without saying. Javier, too, sensed something serious was happening in this city when he heard the story of the skulls and jewels. Dark magic. An evil scheme was brewing in this city. Getting an ominous feeling in his gut, Javier nodded in a serious manner.

“Then, I will return as soon as I come across something. Until then, please be safe, Master Lloyd.”

“Good,” said Lloyd. “You too.”

Javier left through the window, and a gust of fresh air came into his room. Lloyd’s head cleared as he breathed in, and it allowed him to go through his plan once more.

I need proof. I need damning evidence that Cannavaro was the one who buried the skulls and jewels.

Once he found it, he would go look for Count Namaran.

Then, let the games begin. Even if Cannavaro is a dark magician, he’ll be arrested on the spot when the knights ambush his place.

If that were to happen, he wouldn’t have to take any action. There would be no need to take on any dangerous risks. And he’d be able to prevent the incident regarding Namaran’s Wall.

So, Javier, I trust you.

Lloyd knew that Javier would be able to do it. Thinking so, Lloyd sat at the table and counted the jewels he spent all night collecting. And the next day, when morning rolled around, Cannavaro’s eyes swelled with rage when he realized that every single noctanium, the cursed stone, he had buried around Namaran’s wall was stolen.

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Chapter 168: A Philanthropist's True Colors (1)

“Most of the noctaniums have gone missing in the past two days.”

In the basement of Cannavaro’s manor, which was heavily protected with a host of magical devices, there gathered Cannavaro and 30 dark magicians. Seated around a large and elongated table, these 31 magicians relied on only one flickering candle for sight. Cannavaro lifted his gaze against the dim and gloomy scene. With his hands placed on the table, he noticed a fruit fly flying around.

“...”

He was suddenly curious as to how in the world the fruit fly made its way into this space, which allowed no intruders. Then, he wondered if these creatures just came into existence out of a void. This mystery was unsolvable even with his profound magical knowledge. However, he soon pushed the thought away. Something else mattered more, and it definitely wasn’t a fruit fly. The noctaniums had gone missing. He spoke toward the dark magicians.

“As you all know, each was placed in its location after we considered all potential factors. It sat in the area farthest from the gazes and footsteps of the people coming to Namaran, and it was the place that could create the strongest magical vibration for the wall. And yet, the noctaniums went missing. Every one of them.”

“Could it be that Count Namaran has taken notice of things?”

The magicians were wearing a hood that hung down heavily. One of them spoke. Cannavaro shook his head.

“That is not the case. There are no signs that he is on the move,” replied Cannavaro.

“And yet the skulls and noctaniums went missing in the past two days?”

“It is the case, even though it sounds hardly believable.”

“...”

A heavy silence hung over everyone. Cannavaro spoke to break it away.

“We do not know who did this. But an organization or individual with unexpectedly great power is certainly behind this.”

“It is certainly the case. The skulls bore countless magical spells that prevented any robbery, including magic that evades detection.”

It indeed was the case. That was why everyone had lowered their guard. They believed with a firm conviction that no one would be able to discover these skulls, and even if it happened, removing the magic would be an impossibility. But reality turned out to be different.

The magic in the skulls was lifted? And all the noctaniums have disappeared.

Everyone was flustered, and they felt empty. It was like a year’s worth of harvest was stolen in one day. They clenched their fists in rage, recalling the blood, sweat, and tears they put in to produce and bury the noctaniums. But now wasn’t the time to be consumed in anger. Cannavaro, controlling his anger, raked over everyone with his cool gaze.

“Now, let us think objectively,” he suggested, “what’s gone is gone now. There is no point in focusing on what is no longer in our hands.”

“Then, what do you plan on doing?”

“We cannot let this small tribulation become a hurdle to our great cause,” he answered.

“That means...?”

“We will push ahead with the revolt as planned.”

“But how can we?”

One of the dark magicians asked, and his question received several affirming nods from the others. Installing the noctaniums took a lot of time and effort. But the day of the revolution was coming soon, and there was only one final preparation left.

“Our revolution is impossible without the noctaniums. I thought you knew that better than any of us...”

“I know it very well,” Cannavaro replied coolly.

“Then?”

“Instead of installing the skulls, we can activate the wall ourselves. Then, it will go according to schedule without delay.”

“But-”

The dark magician’s mouth, which was revealed under the hood, jerked in dismay. But before they could rebut him, Cannavaro interrupted.

“After all, the skulls were our vehicle in the first place, a proxy to ensure we won’t have to erect the wall on our own.”

“Yes, that’s right. It is important that we do not expose our identity during the revolution.”

“But think about what is important.”

“...”

“Our identities staying hidden? Or is our revolution coming to fruition?”

“...”

“I presume no one in this room will tell us that our safety comes first, am I wrong?” demanded Cannavaro as his gaze swept across everyone at the table.

“Well, that’s-”

“Aren’t I right?”

“...”

Cannavaro’s eyes held a glint of madness. The dark magicians clamped their mouths shut altogether.

“Originally, I wouldn’t have chosen this option, but our hands are tied. The revolution must proceed as scheduled. I’m sure all of you already know. This affair is bigger than us. Our job is only one of the many cogwheels that revolve toward a grander scheme. In other words, our delay will only become an obstacle to the entire group,” argued Cannavaro. “There cannot be any more delay or postponement. We must move forward on our own. But we do not have to take on all the risk like a fool.”

“Do you have any plan in mind?” one of the magicians asked.

“I am thinking of activating the wall at the safest moment.”

“By the safest moment...”

“When the knights in the city all remain in the castle,” replied Cannavaro.

“Oh...!”

Everyone gaped in amazement. Yes. The noctanium wall they planned on erecting was a powerful curse that concentrated life into one place after absorbing the energies of every creature inside the wall. And no one could cross to the other side once it was up. No one could enter from the outside or leave. Penetrating it was impossible unless the person was a sword master. So, if they put up the wall at a time when the knights and other forces were within the castle, no one would be able to come out of it. And they’d be sucked out of life. That alone would eliminate all the enemies that threatened them.

“How about we mobilize reinforced zombies as guards?” one of them suggested.

“Good idea.”

“But I am still concerned. If we expose ourselves when we do not know who stole the noctaniums...”

“You have nothing to worry about.”

“Do you have a backup plan?” asked a dark magician.

“I will protect you all.”

“Are you saying you will protect us?”

“Of course, I will. After all, you all deserve at least that much protection,” answered Cannavaro.

“Oh...”

At last, a sense of relief rushed through everyone. They can stay rest assured if Cannavaro was out there to protect them. He was that much of a powerful dark magician.

“Besides, the defensive magic, a corollary to the magical wall, will protect you all on its own. Only a sword master can hurt you. Otherwise, not a single soul can even touch a strand of your hair. With my protection on top of that, there is nothing you should be afraid of.”

“You speak the truth. I am now relieved.”

The dark magicians grinned, and Cannavaro did so, too, as he looked at them.

Fools.

The promise of giving them protection was obviously a lie. These magicians were nothing but replaceable goods to Cannavaro. Sure, though it was slightly a waste for them to die so easily, nothing mattered more than activating the wall. Once it was activated, there was no way to stop it other than break the wall itself.

“So, now, let us flesh out our plan.”

Hiding his heart that was as venomous as a viper, Cannavaro smiled with great satisfaction.

***

A few days passed.

Now, let's go over the plan once more.

Javier sat as he pondered hard. He stared at his apron, and it was wet because he had intentionally spilled water there. The insides of both his skirt and shoes were wet as well.

"My goodness, what should I do?"

A woman stamped her feet in anxiety, for she thought she was responsible for the spill. That was understandable as Javier bumped into her stealthily and on purpose. And he had let go of the bucket in his hand at that very moment by design.

"My golly! Please watch where you are going, ma'am," said Javier.

"It could have been worse. Miss Ella? Are you hurt?"

People, who were moving food ingredients in the soup kitchen, lashed out at the woman. She apologized several times, thinking that it was her doing. Javier put on a soft smile.

"I am all right," cooed Javier.

"Far from it. Your skirt and shoes are a mess. Whew. You could've hurt your pretty feet because of me. So, do you have clothes and shoes to change into?"

"Um..."

"I suppose you don't."

"..."

She looked more apologetic right now. Javier, too, felt sorry as the pang of guilt attacked his conscience. But he didn't show it. Instead, he simply hung his head and rubbed his hands. That alone did wonders.

"Then, will you change into mine? I left them in the small quarter beside the food storage. Do you know where it is?" the woman asked.

"..."

"It may not be your size, but I am sure it will be better than working in a wet skirt. Go and change, all right? I'm asking because I feel bad."

"Thank you, ma'am."

"Don't even worry about it. It was my fault."

"..."

I sincerely apologize madam, Javier apologized internally as he bowed inside his mind. Then, he hurried out of the kitchen. But he didn't go to the storage as she'd told him. Instead, he made for the Cannavaro's house.

He goes to the basement at this hour.

Javier learned this fact after a few days of observation. He wouldn't have learned this had he not volunteered in the kitchen as a woman and, by chance, ran an errand in the basement. So today, he meant to look into the second floor of the basement. That was why he'd spilled the bucket. He needed an excuse to leave the kitchen.

Sprint! Javier moved like the wind. And his wet apron and clothes hardly mattered at all. One marvelous wringing. That was all it took to lose most water dripping down. And when Javier arrived at Cannavaro's manor, he cut across the garden through the blind spots and rushed into the small door behind the garden. Thankfully, he didn't bump into anyone on the first floor. Like a shadow, he then slipped down to the basement, where the gate stood shut in front of him. It was bolted shut with a magical lock. Javier raised his hand.

Ziiing! Javier rotated one magic circle as he recalled the mana pattern he had seen a few days ago. The mana pattern was in the magical key the butler used to go in and out of this door.

Crackle...! A geometrical shape of mana appeared along his fingertips, and his mana smeared into the lock as it followed the precise and accurate mana pattern. The lock then shone.

Clack. The lock opened.

Perfect.

Javier's eyes glimmered. Surely, he held enough power and strength to break or smash the magical lock as he pleased. But he could not do so. It would leave a trace, which would put the others on alert. This was the moment his efforts of a few days to make his way into the basement came through. Just like that, Javier entered the basement.

"..."

Javier cut across the dim and unpopulated basement and later found a stair that led to the second floor of the basement. But instead of going any further, he stopped in the corner and stood breathless, even stabilizing his palpitating heart and blood flow. Every rhythm in his body and energy were made to harmonize with his surroundings. In other words, he removed all traces of his presence from the area. Then, he waited. First, for ten minutes. Later, for thirty minutes. And when his waiting reached about an hour, Javier heard footsteps from afar.

Step. Step... Someone was approaching, their steps were careful. Javier noticed that the man studied his surroundings at each step to check for anyone hiding around or following behind him. He seemed to have an unwarranted amount of awareness of his surroundings.

Cannavaro.

Javier's eyes were slightly contracted. Cannavaro was down in the basement with a careful look on his face, and he stood in front of the gate to

the second floor of the basement, with Javier watching him. Then he fished something out of his pocket. A mana-loaded key. *Bzzt!*

The mana inside the key entered the lock, vibrating and rotating the magic circle. The lock opened. *Clack!*

Cannavaro looked around once more before heading down to the second floor of the basement. The door finally closed, and the magical bolt was locked. Afterward, Javier stood in the corner without moving for the next 30 minutes until Cannavaro came out again, passed Javier, walked up, and disappeared. But Javier remained rooted to the ground and remained still like a statue. Only when he could not feel Cannavaro's presence did he move again.

"Whew."

Javier was at the gate that led to the second-floor basement. He stretched his hand toward the lock and recalled the mana flow and pattern the key gave off when Cannavaro pulled it out of his pocket. Javier reenacted the same mana pattern using his Asrahan Core Technique. He succeeded in copying it.

Clack. The magical lock opened.

"..."

Javier collected his breath, asking himself what would lie beneath down there and whether what he was doing at the moment was right. That is, his current actions as he was secretly digging around someone's background.

"..."

If Mister Cannavaro's basement was revealed to be nothing special, that is, if it was a secret vault of any other rich men, Javier promised to himself that he would grab Lloyd by the collar and declare that he must accept defeat and keep his promise. Thinking so, Javier grabbed the doorknob and turned it. It opened.

Creak. The door created dissonance as it revealed the basement. And the truth was revealed at the same time.

“Grrr?”

A zombie, aimlessly going around with its head missing, stretched his two arms at Javier.

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Chapter 169: A Philanthropist's True Color (2)

“Grrr?”

A body turned Javier’s way, and Javier saw it lacked a head. It then leaped toward him as its rotting neck jerked spasmodically, its two limping arms outstretched.

“Grrrrr!”

“...!”

He could hardly believe how fast it was, starkly contrasting its limp movement. It reached Javier in a blink of an eye, its tar nails bent on scratching his face. But the very opponent it went against was no other than Javier. In other words, it was out of luck.

Bam! Javier’s legs moved before the zombie could scratch his face, and he kicked it in the gut at the speed of lightning.

“Grr-!”

The zombie, whose voice came out from what was left of its throat, cried aloud strangely as it was sent away by the blow, probably around five yards ahead. The blow shattered its spine when it crashed against the wall. The bone-cracking sound noisily rang aloud throughout the room, and at the same time, the doors on both sides of the corridor snapped open.

“Grrrrr!”

“Grr...!”

More headless zombies flooded out of the doors. That number was about 60. A bitter smile formed on Javier’s face.

“My... Looks like I will become a laughingstock when I return to my fiefdom for a while.”

The sight called to mind the bet he'd made with Lloyd, who insisted Cannavaro was a dirty man with secrets. But he disagreed. He thought that the young master was doubting the man unnecessarily and his order to do a background check on the gentleman was improper. Cannavaro didn't deserve such doubts. That was why he agreed to the bet.

Haa. I cannot believe I have to dress like this when I return to the fiefdom.

Lady Ella. An angel dressed in a modest apron. A goddess of the soup kitchen. Javier was to put on such a disguise the day he returned to Frontera fiefdom. That would be his punishment for losing the bet.

"..."

Javier shuddered, and his hair rose as he thought about it. So, he pushed it away and instead laid his eyes on the sight that was much less frightening than the praises he would earn as Lady Ella in his fiefdom.

"Grrrrrr!"

Roughly 60 headless zombies charged toward him, and the gurgling sound they created clamored in the air. Their hostility was more apparent than before.

Are these reinforced zombies?

They were too fast for an ordinary zombie, and it naturally meant that they would be on another level in terms of strength compared to ordinary ones. But it didn't matter to Javier, who was a sword master. To him, both reinforced and ordinary zombies were nothing but walking corpses. It was the case even when he only carried a block of wood instead of his sword.

Crack!

Javier stretched out his hand and snapped off a leg from a table. Now, he held an excellent club. But did he prepare the club because he needed a weapon? No. It was as the thought of punching the zombies with his bare hands grossed him out.

Craaack! Crack! *Pow!*

Javier's legs alternately moved across the floor, turning and twisting just in time to stab, jab, smack, smite, evade, and shake off the zombies.

Tumble! Kaboom!

Three or four zombies were thrown against the walls each time Javier charged forward through the corridor, and at last, every one of the reinforced zombies was cleared. And when he reached the end of the corridor, he kicked the door open.

Boom! The door snapped open in whole by force, and it landed on a man who was pulling out a weapon.

"Ack!!!"

Now, the door was metal and easily weighed more than ten pounds. Adding the velocity, it was as menacing as any other deadly weapon. The blow knocked him unconscious, but Javier was merciless.

Crunch! He smacked the man's legs with his club and broke them. At the same time, he kicked his six o'clock.

Pow!

"Argh!"

A man, who was trying to ambush Javier from behind, got a blow in his lower chin. He was left unconscious as well. Next, Javier stretched out his club and aimed at the third man's eyes. Javier gazed at him icily.

"Tell me. What you are doing here, and what you're up to. And your relationship with Cannavaro."

"E...eek!"

The third man shivered like a leaf. He was so surprised that he had wet his pants.

Wh-what is this monster?!

The man could not believe this. When he heard the noise of someone walking down to the second floor, he thought it was Cannavaro. But it dawned on him that he was wrong when the first zombie got rammed into the wall. There was an intruder. So he immediately released the other zombies and observed the corridor from a small window attached to a door. The man was hopeful until that point. After all, these 60 zombies were reinforced ones, so he thought that they would be able to rip this intruder to pieces and that he would hear a live man's scream after a long while. So, he remained in his room, watching the fight with an expectant heart. But he saw it. He saw how the groups of zombies were thrown into the walls in mere seconds and how this silver-haired intruder dashed over here afterward. And so, the guy racked his brain, and at last, the name of this intruder, who was pointing at him with a club, came to him.

"E-Ella! Miss Ella?"

"..."

"What are you doing?" The man begged. "You know me, don't you? It's me, the guy who works in the kitchen during the morning-"

"Say that name again," growled Javier, "and you shall never be able to speak again."

Hiccup! Javier's eyes held a glint of iciness, which was colder than an ice rink. The man immediately shut his mouth, intimidated by the former's gaze. And he finally realized that no petty tricks would work. This silver-haired man standing before him was bent on making no concession.

"Wh-what do you want?"

"Truth," said Javier curtly.

"..."

“I asked you a while ago. Your business here. Your plans. And your relationship with Cannavaro. Tell me everything.”

“...”

The man rolled his eyes, laying them on his two colleagues, miserably lying on the ground. But that was a mistake.

Bam!

“...!”

One of his knees was directly hit by a club that suddenly came flying toward him.

“Urghh!”

The man fell to the ground as he clutched his leg. But Javier’s gaze didn’t have any sympathy.

“I’m sure you guys made those headless zombies. But why are they without any heads? Where could they be used for? I think I know,” said Javier.

The things Lloyd had told him several nights before came to his mind. His young master had told him that the former had found plenty of skulls under the ground, which contained mana-loaded jewels. The skulls. The mana-laden jewels. The headless zombies. Javier desperately wished it wasn’t what he thought it was as the puzzles pieced together in his head.

“Speak now. Each time you hesitate, stall, or lie, I’ll break your bones.”

Javier’s gaze was filled with contempt and rage. The man could feel it burning through him as he sat on his knees. He knew that Ella was serious. Her threat wasn’t a bluff.

“I-I...”

The man immediately spoke as fear overwhelmed him by instinct.

“I am a mortician. S-So, are all these men...”

“A mortician?” blurted Javier.

“Yes, sir!”

“Am I the one that’s confused?” asked Javier. “I thought morticians conducted funerals for people, not make zombies.”

“T-the thing is that I learned it from Sir Cannavaro!”

“From Cannavaro?”

“Yes, sir!” hurriedly answered the man.

“Tell me more.”

Javier’s gaze grew bleak, and the man started to speak faster.

“A-as I told you, we were originally morticians. But around the end of last year, mister Cannavaro came up to me and asked if I could help with something that would be worth a lot of money. H-he promised to provide a generous compensation that’s better than I could even imagine...” the man explained.

“So, you learned how to make zombies?”

“H-how else could we have learned to use dark magic then? W-we simply were responsible for taking care of the corpses mister Cannavaro gives us,” defended the mortician.

“Then what about the magic that makes zombies?” probed Javier.

“Mister Cannavaro... And the others...”

“Who?”

“There’s mister Gordo... And mister Mikelan... And most of them work in the trading post. So, those who manage the post and write records with

mister Cannavaro...”

“The workers in the trading post are dark magicians?”

“Yes, yes, sir! I didn’t believe it at first-”

“Then,” interrupted Javier, “why don’t the zombies have heads?”

Javier’s voice was as sharp as cut glass. The Adam’s apple of the mortician bobbed.

“Um...”

“Answer.”

Grip!

When he heard the squeezing sound, the mortician shook off all his hesitation.

“We took care of the head separately.”

“Be more specific,” ordered Javier.

“Um, you see, the thing is... when the corpses arrived, we removed the head first before we cleaned them up. We were told that the skulls were going to be used for a special purpose. So, we cleaned everything inside, leaving only the bone...”

“And?”

“We placed it in all sorts of different solutions. Yes, those were provided to us by mister Cannavaro. I don’t know the exact details either. He said that it was just a valuable magical potion... There were about 15 distinct kinds.”

“That many?”

“Yes, sir. I believe around two days per solution. It took a whole month to treat a single skull using all the potions. Unsurprisingly, we continued to

treat a new skull every two days since there were a lot of different solutions...”

“Then what?”

“Mister Cannavaro and the men in the trading post cast all sorts of magic to it. But we didn’t notice any visible changes,” the man said. “Yet, they all took the skulls with a look of satisfaction. That’s all I know about the skulls... I am telling the truth.”

“No, that’s not all.”

Javier’s face turned stern.

“I get how the skulls are made and how those headless zombies were created. But there seems to be something you have left out. Where did you get the corpses for the skulls and zombies?”

“That’s...”

“Tell me.”

“I-I’m sorry. I really am sorry. Please forgive my crime,” the man said and broke out in tears.

Javier’s eyes remained stern, unmoved. His icy gaze continued to pierce into the man, who flinched and quickly wiped off his tears with a shudder.

“They are... refugees,” the man finally confessed.

“What?” Javier’s voice grew by a pitch.

“They are the refugees mister Cannavaro looked after. They were already sick. Diseased or fatally injured-”

“So, you killed them?”

“Yes...”

“You do know that them being sick doesn’t justify your actions?”

“Th-that’s...”

“And you must have lied to the remaining refugees.”

Javier felt dehumanized, and his mind flew back to what had happened a few days ago. The refugees talked among themselves in the kitchen, how some were being transferred to a protective facility, and how it would be helpful as the place was warmer and more comfortable. But not everyone could be taken there due to its capacity limit...

Most refugees wanted to be taken there. They wished that those who went ahead would be healed completely to open up some slots for them. They waited. Counting down for their day to come.

But it turned out that the place was here. This place of death. The comfortable protective facility didn’t exist in the first place. Javier, wrinkling his nose, asked.

“I heard that there were almost 200 of them,” Javier said.

“Sir?”

“The jewels. The number of skulls that contained those jewels.”

“...”

“I didn’t hear that there were almost 200 terminally ill patients among the refugees.”

“Th-that’s...”

“You couldn’t have possibly killed those that weren’t terminally ill, right?”

“...”

“You did,” Javier said.

“Th-the thing is!” the mortician shouted in a hurry.

“You see! I was told that it was a medicine that makes them comfortable! I really thought so! That’s why, that’s why!”

“You gave it. That is, to the refugees. That’s how you killed them.”

“I really didn’t know!” the mortician pleaded.

“Really?”

“Yes, sir! Yes!”

“Really”?

“Sir...?”

“Who brings a patient to be treated by a mortician? A medicine that provides comfort? What, does the mortician nurse the patient after they take the medicine and get comfortable? Doesn’t that sound ridiculous even in your ears?” demanded Javier.

“Um...”

“Enough with your lies and excuses.”

“Please... Don’t kill me!”

The mortician fell flat on the ground and burst into uncontrollable sobs, his back flinching.

“I sincerely didn’t know this was the job! I just did what I was told. S-so please, extend your mercy-”

“I’m not going to kill you.”

“Sir?”

“I’m not going to kill you,” said Javier again.

“Then that means... T-thank you, sir! Thank you!” The man shouted as he bumped his head to the ground several times in gratitude.

“I am not going to kill you,” said Javier, whose face had grown icier than before. “But do you remember what I told you a while ago?”

“Sir? What are...”

“Each time you lie, I’m going to break one of your bones.”

“Um, I-I...!”

Thwack! The club swung in the air, and it smacked the mortician’s shoulder. The mortician’s face crumpled at the sound of his broken bone.

“A-ack!!”

The mortician collapsed to the ground as he clutched his shoulder. But Javier’s eyes were merciless as he gazed down.

“A medicine that gives comfort? You did not know anything? You merely did what you were just told...? Your excuses are too sloppy and crude. Did you want to try being a good person even in the end? But I don’t think the fairly large amount of money you’d have accepted from Cannavaro reflects that.”

“A-argh! Please d-don’t kill me-”

“I told you,” said Javier coldly,” I am not going to kill you.”

“...!”

Javier lifted his club again. And soon after, the sound of three or four consecutive thrashes rang aloud.

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A little later, Javier went out of the basement. He was now dressed in something else. His silky hair and modest apron had disappeared. Instead,

he wore a black hood that the dark magicians left hanging on the wall. Javier's face was stern and serious under the hood.

I don't have any time to waste.

The truth he had discovered in the basement. The situation he had uncovered through punishing the morticians.

It's more serious than I'd thought. Cannavaro and the dark magicians in the trading post are up to something. I can't leave them like this.

Informing Lloyd and Count Namaran crossed his mind. It was the right thing to do in principle. But he decided that right now was an exception.

Cannavaro and the dark magicians might catch on if the count gets involved.

That would really be the case. If the knights and forces moved to Cannavaro's manor to search and apprehend him, they would lose the opportunity to catch the dark magicians. They might hide and run away.

Master Lloyd, please forgive me. I need to take care of them first.

Act first, report later. Javier made for the trading post after he reached the decision, carrying a sword in his chest covered with a hood and cape.

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Chapter 170: In Front of Namaran’s Wall (1)

A trading post. It was a place that bustled with merchants and facilitated the exchange of goods and currencies between cities. The same went for the trading post in Namaran. It was the most frequented place among the southern and eastern merchants in the kingdom. Although it had grown quieter over the months when the east was wiped out, it was still vibrant nonetheless. However, that wasn’t true today.

“...”

Silence. That was Javier’s first impression of the place when he arrived. There was too much silence when it should have been crowded and jam-packed with people. There were no people in sight, nor any carriages or carts that should have been rolling by at this hour. The laborers, who should be sweating as they carried the cargo, and the merchants, who should be haggling in high-pitched voices, were nowhere to be seen. Not a single person could be found in the front yard of the trading post and the unloading station.

It couldn’t be.

Javier was slightly furrowed, his forehead revealing only somewhat under the hood. Something was happening right now. The truth he had found out in the basement and the silent scene of the trading post overwhelmed Javier with nervousness.

Boom! Javier entered the trading post by kicking its door. Empty. No one was inside. The clerk who should be welcoming merchants when they arrive was also absent.

“...”

Wondering if they had noticed already, Javier raked through the place from the basement to the third floor. But he didn’t find a single soul. It reminded him of an abandoned ship that was in perfectly good condition.

How is this possible? Did they already realize that I found out about their basement?

No, Javier concluded, there was not enough time for that. He had come here as soon as he learned the truth. To do that, he had delayed making a report to Lloyd and Count Namaran.

Five minutes.

That was how long it took for him to arrive here from Cannavaro's house. So, it was unrealistic for Cannavaro and the dark magicians to have realized their predicament and flee after cleaning out this place.

There was not enough time for that. Then why? How is this possible?

Javier debated whether to rush to Lloyd or conduct more searches around the premises. He anxiously walked some more with a lot on his mind. But the moment he grabbed the doorknob to leave...

Boom! A thundering noise blared across the land. But it didn't come from the sky. It came from everywhere around him. Outside the trading post. From all directions. A banging noise, a din of something exploding, roared all around him. At the same time, his stomach churned.

"...!"

His stomach tightened in a flash. His heart started pounding against his will. His vision shook. His mind became foggy in a second. And mana simultaneously slipped out of his body into the air!

What the?

If he wasn't a sword master capable of infinitely circulating mana and instinctively using the Asrahan Core Technique to harness the force of the abundant mana around him, he would have passed out right then and there.

"Argh...!"

Javier shifted his manaheart in a hurry and activated the Asrahan Core Technique. The three-stranded circles rotated to the hilt.

Ziiing! The circles roared as they stopped the sudden discharge of his mana, and it was only then that his stomach and heart calmed down. His vision returned, and his mind cleared.

What in the world is happening?

Javier was shocked perhaps because the air around him had changed so drastically. He wondered if this was the feeling of having the air around you suck the life out of your body. That was when it hit him.

My mana is trying to escape out of my body into the air at a menacing speed.

It was happening even now. So, he had to continue using the Asrahan Core Technique. Otherwise, if his mana circle stopped spinning, he would experience the same thing again.

What in the world just happened?

The blaring noise echoed across the land. The anomalous phenomenon that came after. Something was happening right now. He opened the door, feeling sinister every minute. Then he saw it.

“No...”

The city was enclosed by a giant wall, but it wasn’t physical. It was made of a purplish mana that had a color close to black. It swayed like a heat simmer, wrapping the whole city at a fierce speed. It was hundreds of feet tall, towering over the castle easily and bent on piercing the sky. When the sky above the city was covered with the color of its energy, the sun lost its shine. Its light was now perverted into something purple and beamed down everywhere. And the main road was littered with unconscious people. Every single person in his line of sight was on the ground.

“Hello?” Javier asked after running to one person on the ground. She was an old woman with rich white hair.

“Ah... Ha...”

She was unconscious, and her whole body was shivering. Eyes rolled back, her mouth was overflowing with foam.

“Shoot...”

She was losing mana, much like before he activated the Asrahan Core Technique. But unlike him, she had no means to defend herself. But she wasn’t alone. All of the people on the ground met the same fate as her and went through the same experience. Though Javier couldn’t pinpoint the cause, he could guess somewhat. It was the wall. This sinister mana wall that had surrounded the city. That indeed had something to do with what was happening. It was possible, Javier thought, that the wall was sucking people’s mana out, even the basic amount that was required for survival. Then what about Lloyd?

“Master Lloyd.”

Javier’s heart sank. He wouldn’t be able to push through. It was so even when he had the Asrahan Core Technique and was a mid-level sword expert. He wouldn’t last because he wasn’t a sword master and didn’t learn how to circulate the mana infinitely. He may last a few more minutes, but that would be it. Eventually, he would lose consciousness and be left incapable of using the Asrahan Core Technique as he’s mercilessly robbed of all his mana. And just like that, he would die.

“I apologize for failing to protect you... But I promise I will fix this situation. So, please hold on until then. Please,” Javier apologized as he put her down under a shade.

There was nothing more he could do other than give a heartfelt apology. The only way to save this old woman and all the unconscious people around him was to resolve the situation as soon as possible. Javier ran forward with that in mind. He crossed the main road in front of the trading post, sprinted

across the plaza, and rushed toward the Count Namaran manor. He noticed people lying on the road and those convulsing in the plaza. He even caught the woman from the soup kitchen passed out on the floor. Each time, he bit his lips and ran faster. He sprinted and sprinted, even using up the last bit of mana he had left after activating the manaheart to prevent him from being sucked dry. At last, he arrived at the lodging for the visitors.

“Master Lloyd!”

Bam! He entered after kicking the door and searched for Lloyd. But he was nowhere to be found. Lloyd was not here. Javier sank to his knees.

Where is he?

Javier told himself that he had to hurry and locate Master Lloyd. That was the only way he could save Lloyd and everyone in the city.

Master Lloyd undoubtedly seemed to know something.

Upon more thinking, that was true from the beginning. Javier recalled how Lloyd was suspicious of Cannavaro from the moment Lady Namaran arrived at Frontera fiefdom. And how the latter suddenly inquired about Cannavaro on the first encounter. As such, Javier told himself that Master Lloyd knew something as well as the way to solve this situation. His wisdom. My power. We must work together and help each other out, Javier concluded. That was the only way to save everyone in the city. But... Lloyd was nowhere in sight.

“Master Lloyd!”

Javier tore the whole place down to look for him, his voice growing more hurried and alert.

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“Ah, not here either?”

Stab! A metal shovel dug into the earth, and beads of sweat dripped down near the shovel head stuck deep into the ground. Lloyd’s lips pursed

together as he took in the sight.

“It looks like I came down here for nothing.”

Lloyd lifted his head as he grumbled and looked up at the upper part of the cliff slope. About 30 feet above stood Namaran. Lloyd was way farther down from the sloped cliff of the city, and he was here for a simple reason. To get his hands on more jewels.

Previously, I only searched around the wall.

He had obtained about 200 pieces of jewels that way. Though he was pleased, he wanted some more. He wanted to acquire more jewels as this was a rare opportunity. That was when it hit him that he hadn’t traveled to the lower part of the slope yet.

I had no reason to hesitate.

There wasn’t much to lose from trying. He just needed to break some sweat and do a little more work. From that, he could get lucky and obtain more expensive jewels. So, he immediately took the shovel and sack with him and worked his butt off, exploring the lower part of the slope. But his efforts turned out to be in vain.

“Tsk,” said Lloyd, “I thought I saw a skull.”

Was it around two or three times? He did find some skulls buried underground with his Subterranean Scanning. However, he joyfully dug the earth only to find out they were ordinary skulls. There was no mana or jewel in them.

I think these are actually the bones of those who were executed during ancient times.

“Tsk,” clucked Lloyd again.

Was I too greedy?

He had come to test his luck, to see whether he still had a shot at coming across treasures. But it looked like he was out of luck this time.

Ugh. I'm done. I'm done! I should rest today.

He had sweated enough. Thinking so, Lloyd took the metal shovel and empty sack.

"Ggoming?" Lloyd asked as he looked inside his inner pocket. "Are you asleep?"

"Ggoming...?"

"Tsk. Never mind. Go back to sleep."

Lloyd laughed when he saw Ggoming lifting his head with half-closed eyes after dozing off in his pocket. Lloyd had thought for a split second of riding Ggoming back to the city. But come to think of it again, he realized that it would be wasteful to use a red sunflower seed that way.

I'll just walk to get some exercise.

After packing up, Lloyd started to walk around the road that circled the cliff slope. The late summer breeze felt fresh for the first time in a while.

"The weather is nice."

And the searing heat was no longer painful as a cloud covered the sun just in time. He started to hum before he knew it. But just then, the cloud darkened without any warning. It changed from a fluffy white cloud to a dark thundercloud. At the same time, he noticed a strange vibration of mana coming from the city.

"Huh?"

What is it? What's happening? Lloyd was puzzled. He alternately looked at the sky and the city. Just then, a nearly black mana wall with a purple hue started to get erected.

Bzzt!

"...!"

The wall rocked as it went up like a fog. Then it surged upward at great speed, covering the sun, tearing the cloud, and engulfing the city. Lloyd's eyes widened.

What the? No way. Is that Namaran's Wall?

Lloyd wanted to violently rub his eyes. He couldn't believe the sight he was seeing.

It seems like that is the Namaran's Wall. I mean, it's the same as the illustration I'd seen in the novel. But how is this possible? How?

Lloyd couldn't understand. Surely, he had gotten rid of the skulls and jewels and destroyed the magic circles that enabled the wall. But to his dismay, as though his efforts were all for nothing, the Namaran's Wall was rising up, enclosing the city. And with its dreary, evil, and nauseating energy, it started to usurp all the mana and life that was inside the city wall. It was after he made this realization...

"Dammit. Ggoming!"

Lloyd hurriedly woke Ggoming up.

"I'm sorry. I'll explain later. Eat this first."

"G-ggoming!"

Ggoming seemed to have felt the ominous energy as he was dozing off. He was already wide awake even before Lloyd woke him up. He immediately ate the sunflower seed and grew gigantic. *Wham!*

"Let's go! Above!"

"Ggoming!"

Lloyd hopped on Ggoming, who started to fly up. And they arrived at the city after passing the cliff slopes in mere seconds. But entering the city was impossible.

It's really Namaran's Wall.

Lloyd bit his lips hard. From the sky, he was able to perceive the overall outline of the wall. The blackish-purple mana wall. That opaque wall had completely surrounded the city. There was not a single gap in it. Not even a bird or fly could pass through.

I can't break this.

He wasn't powerful enough. It wouldn't be enough, even if he used the triple mana blast. This cursed wall couldn't be broken even with a sword master's aura. Lloyd wondered if what he was feeling at the moment was what Javier felt in the novel.

Seriously, how did this happen?

Lloyd had put his nose to the grindstone to prevent this situation from happening. But now the wall was up. Lloyd nibbled his lips as he stood before it. I must do something, but what? He asked himself. He must find a way, a way to shatter the wall instead of glancing at the wall so helplessly.

Should I use my RP? Do I need to become a sword master by leveling up my manaheart? No, I don't have enough RP for that. There's a much higher chance that I'll only become a high-level sword expert. Then, should I Ievel up the Asrahan Core Technique? What if I increase the number of circles and use a quadra mana blast instead of the triple? Will that do it?

But Lloyd shook his head.

No. A quadra mana blast won't be enough. The number of blasts doesn't matter here. What matters is combining the mana blast with an aura.

He needed to combine his mana blast with an aura, which held the strength to slice through almost anything. But he couldn't do it. He wasn't a sword

master.

Then what am I supposed to do...

Lloyd felt stuck. And just then, he spotted something on the ground.

“A person?”

Lloyd noticed people scattered all around the wall. There were about 90 people, and it looked like they were in groups of three. Their clothes strangely looked familiar to his eyes. Dark robe. Dark hood. They were exactly the same as the illustration in *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

“They’re the dark magicians!”

A grin appeared on Lloyd’s face. He was happy. Just in time! He shouted internally. He had been racking his brain on how to break through that wall. And here they were. The creators of that wall. For now, it would do to beat them to a pulp. That would enlighten Lloyd on how to discard the wall.

You can take back the wall that’s nothing but a nuisance!

Swish! Gripping his shovel hard, Lloyd ordered Ggoming to take a nosedive toward the nearest dark magician.

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Chapter 171: In Front of Namaran’s Wall (2)

Swooosh! The wind brushed past his ear. Everything in front of his eyes shrunk as the extreme speed overwhelmed his vision. It was incomparably faster than the rollercoaster he had ridden before. But he felt fine and wanted to know why.

It’s do or die now!

Lloyd exclaimed internally. The situation commanded him to take swift action as the wall was now put up and more people inside the city were collapsing to the ground with every passing second. He didn’t have any hesitation left after having that thought. But did he feel that way because he was a man of justice?

To be honest, no... It’s just that the person who’s paying me is in there!

Namaran could not be destroyed. What was more, Count Namaran could not die. The two had to be protected, and the construction had to be completed, so he could get paid. Burning with such determination, Lloyd gripped the shovel in one hand and lowered his body as Ggoming made a steep descent.

Let’s go!!!

The ground neared, and he saw a black-robed man standing there, his outstretched arms facing the wall. There was a mysterious and gloomy mana flowing around him. Lloyd was certain that he was a dark magician. Lloyd’s eyes glimmered.

“Ggoming, now!” yelled Lloyd.

“Ggoming!”

Lloyd gave the saddle a hard tug, and Ggoming spread out his wings, shifting to horizontal flight after a vertical drop. Ggoming then glided across the ground, keeping the drop speed intact and hurtling toward the

magician. When Ggoming brushed past the man, Lloyd immediately lifted his metal shovel and wielded it to strike the warlock's thigh.

Got you!

The blow was impossible to withstand. He was likely to collapse to the ground, grabbing the foot. Lloyd would then figure out a way to neutralize the wall after suppressing him. It was at that moment, that moment when Lloyd drew that hopeful picture in his head, that his metal shovel bounced with a massive repelling force.

"...!"

Lloyd almost lost the shovel as his right grip went numb. In all seriousness, had it not been for the shovel skill and his mid-level sword expert status, the shovel would have left his hands.

"Argh!"

However, holding on to the shovel turned out to be his misfortune. His shovel recoiled and he was forced to bend backward, pushing Ggoming to do just the same.

"G-ggoming!"

Ggoming immediately lost his balance, and his right wing jerked when Lloyd's torso violently tugged to the right. As the direction drastically went to the left, Ggoming lost both altitude and balance. He flapped his wings in a hurry to restore balance and fly up. But it was too late.

"Ggo...ming!"

"Argh!"

In a split second, the ground neared him much too roughly. *Crush!*

"...!"

Drop. Crash. Twist. The ground and sky swirled around Lloyd dozens of times. He couldn’t pull himself together. Lloyd was only able to open his eyes once the rough greeting came to an end.

“Argh...”

His whole body was sore. But he felt comfortable, and soon, he learned that something soft, warm, and comfy had wrapped around him. It was a pair of wings.

“Ggoming?”

Lloyd spoke, goggle-eyed. Ggoming must have wrapped Lloyd with his wings while they were falling. Ggoming had his eyes closed, and so, Lloyd wondered if his friend took the brunt of the fall on his behalf.

“Hey, Ggoming!”

Lloyd’s heart sank. He hurriedly shook Ggoming. He slowly opened his eyes.

“G-ggoming?”

“Ha. Are you all right?” asked Lloyd.

“Ggoming!”

“Are you hurt?”

“Ggomiming! Ggoming! Ggoming!”

Ggoming wasn’t hurt. He was completely fine. But contrary to his confident words, Ggoming couldn’t rise up easily. Lloyd checked on him, and thankfully, he didn’t have any major injuries. It looked like Ggoming simply needed some time to recover from the fall.

Ha. What’s seriously going on?

Feeling slightly relieved at last, Lloyd shook his head as his muscles screamed in pain. He then picked up the shovel tossed nearby and turned to look at the warlock. A scoff escaped Lloyd.

“Hahaha...”

The warlock still looked perfectly fine, even though Lloyd had definitely hit him with a shovel earlier. The man still had his arms stretched out toward the sky. In other words, he was completely unharmed.

Wait, is he using a protective spell?

Lloyd wrinkled his nose. It looked like so. The blow he just sent to the magician was substantial. Ggoming had ramped up his speed to the max with the drastic drop. There were also his and Ggoming’s weights to consider. On top of everything, it was infused with the mana that came from his manaheart. The blow contained enough power to dominate most lancers in heavy cavalry. It was comparable to being directly hit by a van.

But all that power completely bounced off him. And thanks to it, we crashed to the ground.

Lloyd trembled when he thought how his bones could have been crushed and shattered without Ggoming's protection during the drop. So, he tapped Ggoming as the latter recovered from the impact.

“Thank you,” said Lloyd, “Just wait here for a moment.”

“G-ggoming!”

Lloyd left Ggoming alone and approached the dark magician. If hitting him didn’t do, he would use the mana blast to defeat him. Thinking so, he tightened his grip on the metal shovel.

“Grrr!”

“Grr!”

But Lloyd was immediately stopped by the appearance of two creatures. Both didn't have any heads, and they reeked of rotting fish, assaulting Lloyd's nose. They were zombies. Worse, they were headless zombies.

"I saw from the sky that they were scattered about in groups of three. So, it seems like there are two zombies and one warlock in each group."

It appeared so, indeed.

This is a little overwhelming.

Lloyd shrugged, his shoulders flinching as the pressure to fight against the zombies weighed down on him. Right off the bat, it was harmful to his mental and eye health to see the gory creatures in real life. Then there was the stench.

Goodness, I wish I could just cut my nose off right now.

If he was guilty of anything, it would be that he rose to become a mid-level sword expert. Now that his senses were sensitive by multifold, he feared that his nose cells would rise up against him and beg for their destruction. However, Lloyd knew that he could not retreat, and there was no reason to, either. After all, he held an excellent optional skill for suppressing zombies. Hurriedly opening the skill window before the zombies jumped at him, Lloyd activated his optional skill of manaheart.

Ding dong.

[Manaheart Skill Option ④: Zombie Domination has been activated.]

"Grrr?"

The two zombies jerked visibly right before they charged at Lloyd. But that was it, and nothing more. They soon turned hostile. Simultaneously, a disappointing message appeared in front of him.

[The two zombies that were targeted for domination do not have heads. As such, they cannot "face" you. The important condition of Zombie

Domination has not been satisfied.]

[You have failed to dominate the zombies.]

“Grrr!”

Bam! A headless zombie charged at Lloyd, who was reading the message in the background. He wrinkled his nose.

“Oh, come on!”

He didn’t want to fight. However, he wasn’t going to stall if it was inevitable. Hell-bent on taking them down, Lloyd avoided the attacks from the zombies charging at him like a bull. He slid his shovel and pushed them to the side, putting them to bump into each other. Their legs got caught on one another and fell to the floor in one lump.

“Grrr!”

They let out another ferocious roar and flailed to get to their feet. But that was the last movement they could manage. Before they touched the ground, Lloyd blasted their bodies with his mana blast. *Kaboom!*

“Gr-!”

The mana blast that shot out from the metal shovel penetrated their bodies until it began to expand, growing 20 inches in diameter in just mere seconds. Everything within the range took the effect of the blast.

Boom! Their bodies vanished. That was the end of them.

“Tsk,” clucked Lloyd.

Though it was a relief that the zombies were taken care of, he felt worse. If he was being honest, the zombies didn’t do anything wrong. He was rather sorry for them.

Technically speaking, they’re the bad guys.

Lloyd’s gaze traveled to the warlock standing some feet away. That warlock deserved to be beaten to death. That evil figure was nothing but a pest. A horrible menace to society who killed innocent people to use them as zombies and put up a strange wall that sucked the life out of those inside it.

So, one blast for you too.

He would take the warlock down but not kill him. Instead, he would beat the daylights out of him until he confessed the method to neutralize the wall. Flashing with deadly determination, Lloyd stared at the warlock as he got ready for another blast. And he shot.

Kaboom! The violent wave of rough mana came out from the outstretched shovel and made its way as it pierced the space. It then hit the warlock’s leg. But it bounced off him. *Plop!*

“Huh?”

Lloyd widened his eyes in disbelief. It was a mana blast!

Did it bounce off?

He struggled to believe what he just saw. But he couldn’t deny what happened in front of him.

Is this real life?

Lloyd pondered if he should use the triple mana blast. But he soon told himself that there was no guarantee. What else should I do? He asked himself, falling into deep thought. And later, Lloyd noticed something strange and unusual about the warlock.

Hold on. That warlock hasn’t been moving since a while ago.

It really was the case come to think of it. Even when Lloyd struck him hard with a shovel in the air with Ggoming, when he fought with the zombies, and when he fired the mana blast. The warlock remained standing like a statue whose arms were stretched out toward the sky. This only meant one thing.

“Hey,” called Lloyd. “Can you not move?”

He sounded the warlock out, slowly approaching him and speaking when he was about five steps away. But no response came from the warlock. There wasn’t any reaction from him either. Actually, there was one, though it was menial. He rolled his eyes to Lloyd’s side, but his whole body stayed frozen.

“Ha,” said Lloyd. “It really is the case. You can’t move.”

Lloyd found himself laughing. The situation started to make a little more sense.

That warlock can’t move while he maintains the wall he’s erected. That’s why he protected himself with a powerful protective spell.

The protective magic was so strong that it bounced the massively strong blow from his shovel and even the mana blast. A sense of confusion rushed through Lloyd when he realized this.

What should I do then?

Lloyd thought hard about it. Triple mana blast? Supercharge? As he racked his brain for a solution, he felt a flow of familiar mana from the warlock.

“Huh?”

Lloyd lifted his head, and his gaze followed where he could feel the flow of the mana. It was in the warlock’s chest. And there he saw it.

“A jewel?”

A dark purplish gem was stuck to his necklace. Lloyd walked closer to him, even openly observing the stone in the necklace. That was when he knew.

It’s the same thing.

The skull he had dug from the ground and the jewel in it. The warlock carried the same kind. Even the mana flow in the stone was almost the

same. A mana so drearily and gloomily concentrated was jolting heavily, reverberating the wall around Namaran. So, I was right, Lloyd said to himself, this stone was the means through which the warlocks put up the wall. Now, things were different. From that moment onward...

Bingo.

The corners of his lips rose as he had a lightbulb moment. Lloyd had acquired rich amounts of those gems by removing the mana to the point that he had grown accustomed to their mana structure. And here was a warlock using that in front of Lloyd.

It's like he set down a meal in front of me to enjoy.

Lloyd didn't have to needlessly struggle to break the wall. He just had to take care of the magical source that fueled the wall. And in this scenario, there was a better method than merely disposing of it.

"Hey, man."

Lloyd smugly stared at the warlock after recovering his usual composure. And of course, the warlock didn't say anything. Lloyd continued to talk to him.

"You must feel very relaxed," Lloyd asked, "Confident, aren't you? You have the protective magic with you, after all. You're pretty confident and relieved that my smacking, kicking, pinching, and anything else I could possibly do won't work, right?"

"..."

The warlock shot Lloyd a gaze, the kind wherein he seems to scoff and say, "Duh!" But Lloyd wasn't affected by this unnecessarily. In a moment like this, the one who reacts first loses. Lloyd simply responded by smiling more, by deepening his crow's feet.

"Relax. Why should I punch you? I don't want to waste my energy. Instead, I just have to attack the center."

“...”

“Oh, what is that? You’re asking me what I mean? Listen carefully. You see this gem you have? I’m going to alter its function.”

“...!”

“Oh, yes, I sure can. I know how to do it,” said Lloyd.

“...”

“I’m serious! You want to see?”

Lloyd held out his hand and grabbed the noctanium stuck in the warlock’s necklace.

“You see, I may not know magic well, but I’m pretty good at absorbing and rearranging mana. Plus, I spent so many hours of my life drawing blueprints that I can do it in my sleep now. You get what I mean?”

“...”

“This gem of yours. I’m going to alter the mana pattern concentrated in it. And so, I’ll change whom the wall will try to absorb the mana from. From the people inside the wall to those who are responsible for it. That is, you.”

“...!”

The warlock’s eyes shone with doubt. Just then...

Ziiing! Still clutching the gem, Lloyd rotated his three-stranded mana circle and ran the Asrahan Core Technique, a skill especially fit for absorbing and rearranging mana.

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Chapter 172: In Front of Namaran's Wall (3)

Ziiing! The noctanium shivered violently in Lloyd's tight grip. It was its way of resisting and fighting.

This is no joke!

Lloyd involuntarily flinched as he realized that the gem the warlock wore in his necklace was not to be taken lightly.

It's going berserk.

Lloyd's brow quirked. It felt like he was riding an untamed wild horse or driving up a hill in a truck with a broken brake. But Lloyd didn't care about it at all. He simply spun the mana circle faster, absorbing and discharging the force coming from the gem as it resisted him. At the same time, he sent a portion of his own mana into the gem. This was only possible because he had the Asrahan Core Technique with him.

Let's see.

Lloyd closed his eyes and focused his senses on the mana he put inside the jewel. The mana structure of the jewel appeared to him like one panorama.

It's complex.

It looked like a labyrinth, whose countless dots, lines, and sides crisscrossed and jumbled in a mess. Lloyd suddenly felt like he had become a provincial boy arriving in the main capital city of the country or a newbie driver who came out to the busiest part of the street during rush hour right a day after he got the license. The structure was overwhelmingly complex. He felt a sense of transcendental bleakness and confusion. It felt like he was trapped inside a jungle. But Lloyd didn't allow himself to be dismayed. Instead, he pulled himself together all the more with steadfast determination.

This is a blueprint. A design outline. I just need to imagine it's one that my groupmates majorly messed up on. So, what now? I need to fix it. Modify it.

That way, I can save my grade and keep my scholarship!

Losing his scholarship was the worst thing that could happen to him, as he barely met his rent. Without a scholarship to cover his tuition, he'd have to spend one whole year working after filing for a leave of absence. He didn't want that since it meant delaying when he'd get a job and prolonging his tiring life in poverty.

My engineering degree! I have to get it fast!

Lloyd yelled as he remembered his emotions during college. Mind control. Success. From then on, he was able to maintain composure amid the complicated and frustrating mana fuse. He remained composed, identifying the whole space with aplomb. Then, in a slow and measured manner, like untangling a yarn, Lloyd analyzed all of the dots, lines, and surfaces in front of him. He identified the structure of the mana in the gem and understood it. And soon, the solution appeared on its own. Lloyd learned which areas he should fix or change and what kind of results it would bring. A smile formed on his face when he figured everything out.

You guys are all dead.

Now, he knuckled down, modifying the mana structure, which turned out to be a breeze when he had it all figured out. The job was very familiar, after all.

It's more than familiar. I've done this so many times that I'm sick of it!

This was a blueprint, and he was tasked to fix it. Such an approach comforted Lloyd, who boldly and carefully revised and rearranged the mana pattern of the noctanium. After some time, the results of his efforts started to show.

Crackle...! A portion of Namaran's Wall began to shake. Even the color of the sky changed. Its ominous signature color of black with a purple hue shifted into a light glowing complexion, and the warlock's face simultaneously changed.

“Humph...!”

The warlock sucked in his breath involuntarily, and his eyes snapped open in horror. Was it because he was surprised? No.

The mana... in my body!

It was leaving his body at a rapid speed and absorbing into the wall.

Argh!!

The warlock’s heart pounded irregularly, yet he couldn’t do anything. The noctanium was already activated and could not move due to the protective magic. And there was no canceling it.

How... How?!

The warlock was terribly dismayed. The man, Lloyd, had suddenly appeared before him and shot his mouth off about how he could change the target of the mana absorption. The warlock thought it was all a bluff, and his reaction was only natural because what this man said was beyond common sense. An impossibility. But now, he learned that he was wrong. Every word the man said proved to be true!

How? How in the wooor...

He couldn’t endure any longer. The warlock despaired, but he couldn’t fight. With his arms stretched forward, he was robbed of his mana. His vision grew hazy. His hair fell out in clumps. His skin grew wrinkly, and the blood in his body dried up. His muscles quickly atrophied. His liver and heart shrunk. He was being mummified alive. Even his last drop of mana got stolen by the devouring power of the wall. Lloyd opened his eyes right after.

“…That scared me.”

Lloyd opened his eyes to meet the warlock’s face that had turned into a mummy. Since he was standing close, clutching the necklace, Lloyd almost took in a full shot of the mummy’s face.

“Ugh. Seriously.”

Lloyd hurriedly stepped back as he shook off his goosebumps. The upright warlock had already died. Though Lloyd felt a little wistful, he didn’t necessarily pity him. After all, he reaped what he sowed. This was his own doing after trying to massacre thousands and tens of thousands of people using that awful wall. When Lloyd thought about how he was only paying the price of his sins, he didn’t feel bad at all and quickened his pace.

“I don’t have any time to space out like this. Ggoming!”

“Ggoming!”

Ggoming fluttered his wings and strutted toward Lloyd when he called. To Lloyd’s relief, it looked like he had recovered pretty well from the shock.

“Can you fly?” asked Lloyd.

“Ggoming!”

“Really? Are you sure? You don’t have to push yourself if it’s too hard. I can just run around instead,” comforted Lloyd.

“Ggomiming! Ggoming!”

Ggoming eagerly shook his large and round head.

“Ggoming! Ggomiming!”

“What did you say? Even so, the situation is serious, so you can’t just sit still and watch?”

“Ggoming!”

Then Ggoming turned around, prompting Lloyd to hop on quickly. As he did, Lloyd already had his eyes on the next target. Another warlock was standing quite far from the cliff slope. He, too, was standing up with his arms stretched out.

“That way. I see another one there. Let’s go!”

“Ggoming!”

Ggoming spread out his wings forcefully, and Lloyd fixated his eyes on the next target.

You guys are all dead meat.

Lloyd made up his mind to change the target of the wall so that it would absorb the dark magicians’ mana instead. And next, he would take their jewels from them. Every single one of them. His heart pounded in excitement at the thought.

***

Meanwhile, something was brewing in the public hall that stood in the city downtown. Owned by the count, this structure served as a meeting room, conference room, and lecture hall for the people. Today was the same. The public hall bustled with visitors who came to enjoy various artworks by local artists. Happiness permeated the air as everyone enjoyed, admired, and complimented the art pieces and conversed with one another. But this scenery took an abrupt halt just 30 minutes ago.

“That is what is so ironic about life. You never know what lies ahead of you. Don’t you think?”

Cannavaro smiled. He was Namaran’s most famous celebrity and gentle philanthropist, making him the subject of admiration for all the people here. This man was known for his smile. It never left him, even in bad times. That smile of his warmed anyone who laid their eyes on something so innocent and mellow. His smile was almost symbolic. The same went for today. About 30 minutes ago, most citizens flashed a grin at him when he showed up at the public hall. They thanked him for visiting the exhibition despite his busy schedule and how they were glad to see him. He responded to them with the same content smile, and that was when Namaran’s Wall became activated.

“It doesn’t just apply to people’s behavior but their inner thoughts as well. Everyone considers me a philanthropist. They say they respect me. But do you think no one thought otherwise? I doubt it. There probably were those that cursed me, saying that I’m boosting my ego by squandering my money this way. Yet, they would have still smiled in front of me just in case I might give them something nice. Well, I get it. That’s just the way of life.”

Cannavaro’s magnanimous smile twitched. A corner of his lips rolled upward, and his gaze moved to a guy on the floor. The man looked to be in his 30s. He was a knight under Count Namaran.

“Argh...!”

Unlike the rest of the people, this knight had not passed out yet. He was dearly holding onto his fading consciousness as his body convulsed from the flood of mana leaving him. He had only one reason. It was because of his young daughter in his embrace.

“Why... are you... doing this?!”

The knight muttered, obviously racked with excruciating pain. He couldn’t wrap his head around this whole thing. Why is this happening? Why is mana leaving my body this fast? Is this how I, my daughter, and everyone else die? So meaninglessly? The knight asked himself. He was simply enjoying a vacation with his daughter. As he wondered about the cause behind this incident and the way to save his child, fear and resentment flooded his heart in the face of the hopeless situation. And making things worse, Cannavaro looked perfectly fine amid this tragedy. It looked like he didn’t have any mind to help people out. Heck, it looked like he was enjoying it. That terrified the knight more.

“What do you mean why?” Cannavaro’s thin lips rose to form a scoff. “Quietly perish like the good sacrifice you are.”

“What...”

Wham! Cannavaro kicked the knight’s head, and he instantly passed out. Cannavaro, once a philanthropist but now a warlock, hummed as he walked

away. He pushed and shoved people in his way as though he was cleaning up trash from the road, heading toward the biggest sculpture in the exhibition.

“Ha.” A chuckle escaped Cannavaro as he looked at the sculpture. “The fall of an angel?”

The sculpture was of an angel crumpled on the ground after losing his wings and crashing down. But his head was looking up straight at the sky. His gaze did the same as though he was blaming the one who took away his wings and resolved to take revenge. It was an image of a fallen angel sending a gloomy and venomous gaze at the sky.

“This artwork pairs very well with the revolution today.”

His smile grew more content. He brought his hand to his lips and bit it hard. Blood came out of his finger, and he stroked the body of the angel, drawing a variety of strange patterns. His smile deepened in the process. Now, the preparation to summon Hell’s Knight was finished. All that was left for him to do was wait.

I only have to wait until midnight.

He would have enough mana by then, and Hell’s Knight would reign on this land, turning this kingdom into a living hell. As Cannavaro was getting emotional at the thought...

“Ah...”

Cannavaro heard a groan from behind, and he looked back with reflex. A strange sight caught him.

“Cannavaro... Have you lost your mind?”

The knight who had passed out was coming back to his senses. Still hugging his daughter tight, he glared tiredly at Cannavaro.

“Hah,” huffed Cannavaro.

What happened? How did he recover consciousness after passing out?

There would be nothing strange about it if it had been any other day. However, the wall was currently erected.

Sure, he was just barely able to hold on using his manaheart earlier. However, he should have never been able to wake up after passing out due to all the mana he lost during that time. It was beyond Cannavaro, but he didn't worry about it. If this knight was up again, then he should simply stomp him back to unconsciousness again. He was about to walk toward the knight when...

"Ugh...!"

"Mom... Mom..."

He started to hear groans coming from all directions. It was from the people, who were lying flat throughout the public hall. Each of them slowly mumbled, writhing in pain, and opening their eyes. They were waking up, lifting their heads as they looked around in confusion and agony.

What's going on?

Cannavaro's smile trembled. Something that was impossible was taking place. As though it wasn't enough with the knight bearing the manaheart, all the ordinary citizens had begun to regain consciousness one after another.

How is this possible?

Cannavaro turned with a sunken heart, wondering if something had happened to the wall. Something was definitely wrong. The people couldn't wake up when their mana had been sucked out of them. Only one could remain safe within the wall, and it was he who was protected by his noctanium and exempted from the curse.

So, why? How?! How in the world are these peasants coming back to their senses and sending a look for help at him? I have to check now!

Growing hasty, Cannavaro bolted out of the public hall and checked outside. His eyes widened in fright when he saw the wall.

“The wall is...”

It had changed. Instead of a blackish purple, it was glowing in various colors. And people around the public hall started to wake up one by one.

“...”

It was clear now. There was definitely a problem with the wall, and it was no longer absorbing mana. But that wasn’t the end of his despairing realization. Amid the groups of lethargic people painfully opening their eyes, Cannavaro noticed a silver-haired man walking over his way.

Swish. Javier Asrahan. The silver-haired knight drew his sword as soon as he laid his eyes on Cannavaro. When their eyes met, Cannavaro was gripped with fear. For the first time ever, his smile vanished from his face.

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Chapter 173: Blood and Iron vs. Hell (1)

Where could Master Lloyd be? That question had dominated Javier's thoughts the most today. To be technically correct, that question dominated Javier for the past 20 minutes. He wanted to find his young master but couldn't. From the moment he left the count's manor and his lodging, he sprinted across the plaza and the main road, passing through every alley and opening every door within sight. Javier yelled until his voice gave way. But Lloyd didn't answer. There was only desperate groaning of the citizens on the streets. His heart grew hastier in those moments because he was forced to overlook them and because of his mission to find Master Lloyd any second faster. He ran desperately as his heart sped. After some time, Javier noticed mana gathering to one point, and that was the wall that enclosed the city in an ominous manner. The absorbed mana was concentrated in one place. So he rushed there, hoping to find Lloyd there. He ran and ran until he arrived and saw.

"..." It was Cannavaro, the man responsible for this incident. Javier drew his sword the moment he discovered him from afar.

Swish! The sword in his hand glinted coldly. Cannavaro's eyes widened in fright at the same time.

How is he okay?

Cannavaro's heart sank when he saw the silver-haired knight that appeared in the distance. From the moment their eyes met, the former's heart pounded violently, and his instinct yelled danger.

Sure, the wall is not working properly right now, and the mana absorption has been paused... But it was working properly until a while ago. So, the wall should have drained all his mana!

But strangely, the silver-haired man stood fine, collecting his breath slightly as if he'd rushed to get here. And he was holding a shiny sword that was shining brighter than his glowing eyes. From the moment Cannavaro

realized this silver-haired man was dangerous, which was a second after their eyes met, Cannavaro immediately moved his hands.

“Hmph!”

His fingers and palms interlocked, and they pulled away again quickly. The mana was then connected, assembled, distorted, and torn according to consistent regulation and arrangement. And then, he pushed it in the air.

Fwoosh! A spatial door opened in front of his outstretched hands. Darkness within darkness. Perhaps the end of another dimension—hell. Something charged out of the door.

Clink! A metal chain composed of 13 links poured out. Each link was as large as a large tree trunk. There was more.

Cruuush! The chain swept through, and everything in the area crumbled to pieces. But it wasn’t because of its force and power. As though the chain could fast-forward time a thousand times, everything it touched became old, corroded, crumbled, and broke. The rocks, the earth, and the carriage... There was nothing left untouched. But Javier didn’t even bat an eye.

“…”

It was nothing. That was Javier’s take on the incoming chain. Next, his sword moved.

…!

There was no sound or flash. It was just a horizontal cut, and everything that charged toward him split in half. The chain and its fierceness were cut in one stroke. Everything the sword slashed and touched emitted a brilliant light.

Crackle! The aura that developed all of a sudden snapped the chain. It swept through the space and added more momentum to its movement. When Cannavaro saw it happen, he immediately turned and ran toward the public hall without looking back once. It was only natural that he did

because he knew that he would die if he hovered around this place. That much was clear to him.

Crap! Is that a dragon or something?!

Cannavaro hurriedly opened the door to the public hall as a thought crossed his mind. Is he a sword master? No. Even a sword master was incapable of doing that, which was creating an aura that cut through his strongest dark magic in one stroke right after having been usurped of mana for almost an hour inside the wall.

I don't know who he is, but he's not just a simple sword master. He may not be a human, to begin with.

Cannavaro couldn't think of anything else. But his misunderstanding was truly only natural. After all, he was ignorant of Javier's arrival in the city as Lloyd had kept his visit here unofficial and discreet. Lloyd and his delegation simply joined Lady Namaran and her delegation to get here, and after such a quiet arrival, Lloyd proceeded with the construction right away. As such, Cannavaro never learned that a renowned silver-haired knight lodged in this city worked in his soup kitchen, and came here to execute the former. Although Cannavaro knew nothing of this, one thing was clear. He was in a crisis.

I'm going to lose unless I do something.

Cannavaro had no doubt that he'd be done for. After all, the previous magic was the best he could come up with, but it was sliced in one stroke. No tricks or gimmicks would ever be enough to overpower that man with silver hair.

Then...

Cannavaro's gaze moved nervously toward the center of the main hall, particularly to the fallen angel sculpture. It was covered with shamanistic symbols drawn in blood.

"..."

Hell’s Knight. Cannavaro wondered if he should summon it now. But the wall was broken, and mana wasn’t enough. There could be complications even if he summoned it.

But if I don’t summon it right now... I’ll die.

His deliberation was short-lived, and the decision was made in no time. Cannavaro placed his hand on the sculpture, which was all ready for a ritual minus the final activation. Starting the summoning rite was easy, as all he had to do was imbue some mana into his hand. That was enough.

Ziiing!

The bloody symbols marked all over the sculpture beamed with a scary light, and at the same time, a legion of mysterious ghosts appeared and floated around, emitting light as they wiggled, surged, rose, yelled, and convulsed. And at last, the sculpture shrunk and burst.

Thwack!

“Argh!”

Cannavaro was knocked to the ground after one of the rocks that splattered following the explosion hit him. Though his wounded forehead bled profusely, he didn’t even think of wiping it off. He instead looked up and checked the creature he had just summoned.

“Hell’s Knight...”

Psssh... A dark fog flowed down from the marble display where the sculpture once stood before the explosion. A red glow, which came from its eyes, glimmered, and it looked around in one breath and removed the fog on the second breath, finally revealing its form. But there was something off about it.

“What...”

Cannavaro scowled as his gaze hurriedly studied the whole length of the knight’s body. When the dark fog that veiled the creature cleared,

Cannavaro could easily spot its defects. It wasn’t riding the Horse of Hell. It lacked one arm and leg. In other words, it was single-armed and legged and without a horse.

“Arggh! What the heck?!”

Cannavaro wrapped and squeezed his head with his hands in despair. I’m doomed! He shouted internally. As expected, it was all due to the mana absorption glitch in the wall. It had failed to sufficiently collect mana, and there wasn’t enough to summon a proper Hell’s Knight.

But still! How?!

All the effort and money he had invested up to this point and his grand plan waiting to be achieved popped into his head. Despair. His legs gave way, and he keeled over. And he looked up at the lacking Hell’s Knight with a disappointed gaze. Just then...

“Did you do all this to summon that?”

A voice rang aloud in the public hall. It was Javier, who was already inside. He was frowning, his steps careful and alert. And his gaze was fixated on Hell’s Knight.

“...”

As Javier stared at Hell’s Knight, it also turned its gaze at him. Blue eyes and red eyes. Their gazes met. The next moment, they were already clashing their swords. They had understood from the moment their eyes locked that the other was an enemy.

Clack! The long silvery sword clashed with the black two-handed sword. The brilliant aura collided with the cursed energy. These contrasting characters initiated an unyielding power struggle, and the moment their swords struck one another, the impact created a massive storm that swept across the whole area. Javier’s eyes widened.

“...!”

Its force was beyond his imagination, and his sword nearly moved backward. But something else was more surprising.

From my hands to my shoulders, my bones are sore.

Javier furrowed as he recalled the clash a moment ago. Right when their swords collided, icy energy traveled from its sword body and entered him, penetrating into his skin as deep as his muscle tissues and marrows. It invaded his system as it followed the veins upward from his elbow. Had Javier failed to rotate the mana circle right after he sensed the invasion and pushed it away with intense mana pressure, his heart would have been seriously damaged.

He's a powerful foe.

The knight wasn't just any other strong undead or skeleton soldier. It wasn't to be taken lightly because it lacked an arm and leg. With only one clash, Javier managed to almost precisely identify its capacity.

It's as strong as me.

It became clear to Javier that this knight was more powerful than an ordinary sword master like Queen Magentano. There should be two or three of her kind to put up a fight. This meant that if this hellish creature came with both arms and legs, Javier would not stand a chance, either.

But not now.

Javier was certain that he could do it. He could. Convicted, Javier's blue eyes flashed with fierce determination. His sword became more precise and violent by a notch.

Thud! Twang!

Javier, the knight of blood and iron, attacked his enemy without any mercy. When Hell's Knight sliced, he whammed from the other side to change the direction upward, and when it tried to defend the attack, Javier stabbed it.

"...!"

Hell’s Knight’s skull jerked violently, and it wondered if all humans on earth were like this man. It was thrown into such confusion as the very first human it fought after landing on the earth was no other than Javier.

“What the...”

It had heard that humans were weak. So, it was convinced that no one in this world would ever be enough to stop it even though it came in imperfect shape and could only harness half of its original power. Unfortunately, its conviction shattered within a minute when its rib was slashed by a sword.

Crash! The long silvery sword slashed through Hell’s Knight’s chest, and the armor and ribs fell to the ground. But of course, Hell’s Knight wasn’t going to stay still and let this human attack so freely.

“...!”

It shouted the language of hell and wielded its sword, creating a cursed shockwave that swept across the whole area in front of it. But Javier didn’t bother to evade the attack. Instead, he simply accepted it head-on.

Swing! Javier started to stab the air at lightning speed with his long sword, the sheer speed turning the sword invisible. Next, he calmly used the mana blast to pierce the shockwaves Hell’s Knight produced. Javier stretched his hands further, aiming at the skull of his enemy. The mana blast was fired and pierced its skull.

Crack! The mana blast penetrated the front of Hell’s Knight’s helmet, digging further into its skull. And at last, it was shattered to pieces.

“...!”

Hell’s Knight’s whole body convulsed now that its head was gone. And a second later...

Clank! Its sword fell from its hand. The entire joint fell apart to the ground like a sand castle collapsing. This was the moment when Hell’s Knight, the

very knight from hell who overpowers sword masters, was reduced to ashes.

“What is...”

Cannavaro gaped, his mouth hanging down wide open. He couldn’t even blink. The clash between Javier and Hell’s Knight had involved a complicated exchange of attacks and defenses, but to an untrained eye like Cannavaro’s, it merely lasted a few seconds. As such, from Cannavaro’s perspective, the very creature he worked so hard to summon was ultimately reduced to a pile of bones after only lasting for a few seconds.

Am I... having a nightmare?

Cavannaro kneeled over to the ground as strength left his legs. Gutted, he looked up at the silver-haired knight who was approaching.

“If you had committed a common serious felony, it would be only proper to execute you on the spot,” announced Javier gravely. “But you committed too many crimes, so you must be taken into custody in the palace.”

“...”

The long sword was now pointing at Cannavaro. He gulped as he saw its tip.

Where in the world...

Where in the world did this monster come from? Cannavaro could not believe he wasn’t dreaming as he looked at Javier. That sense of shock and daze was actually understandable. Javier was perfectly fine even when he was currently inside the noctanium wall. And even though it had defects, he was able to easily defeat Hell’s Knight. Even though he saw everything with his own eyes, it still seemed unrealistic.

Is he a dragon pretending to be a human? No, that’s just not possible. A dragon will never intervene in human affairs without reason. If so... If so... Hold on, is he...?

Cannavaro paused. After straining himself to restore composure and racking his brain, Cannavaro remembered something.

Javier Asrahan.

He had heard of the name. Javier was said to be a young sword master that appeared from nowhere and was stronger than the queen. It was also rumored that he was gorgeous with silvery hair, which resembled a constellation. And now, the very monster that was approaching him with a sword in hand fit the description very well.

But what's he doing here?

There was no way that Cannavaro would not have known Javier Asrahan came to the city. Could it be, Cannavaro mused, that he came here on an unofficial visit? Could it be that he had seen through the revolt in advance? There was no way of answering. But he didn't despair, for his eyes spotted something behind Javier just when he thought the end had come.

"Haha, ha!"

The corners of Cannavaro's lips rose involuntarily. A pile of black bone was regenerating on its own and getting back on its feet behind Javier.

Crack... Crack...! The Hell's Knight's black skull helmet was restored in no time. And now, its eyes held a glint of more menacing hostility.

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Chapter 174: Blood and Iron vs. Hell (2)

Creak! Creak...! A sinister noise echoed through the public hall. The joints of Hell's Knight rose up and were swept by a black magical force. It was as though it had received the blessing of an immortal being and had never been crushed to pieces. The bones were assembled from its legs to the pelvis, spine, ribs, shoulders, and skull. The dark armor then covered its whole body. A helmet was thrown on.

Flash! A reddish glow, which was its eyes, glittered inside the helmet. At the same time, Hell's Knight stretched its one hand, the huge two-handed sword lifting from the ground to fly back into its grip. A fierce mana was set ablaze around its giant blade. At the same time, Cannavaro broke into laughter.

"Haha, ha! Hahaha!"

Cannavaro, who had been dropped to the ground, hurriedly crawled far away from Javier.

"Oh, my Hell's Knight! Execute our enemy! Quickly!"

Cannavaro's sharp shouts rang aloud in the public hall, prompting a reaction from everyone inside. The collapsed citizens painstakingly lifted their heads and stared at Cannavaro even while a pang of dizziness continued to haunt them. Their gazes were filled with disappointment, resentment, and hatred. That man used to be a gentle philanthropist, the pride of the city. But now, he was nothing but a traitor who revealed his true color. But Cannavaro nonchalantly ignored their gazes. He didn't care at all about them. His gaze was laser-focused with admiration on Hell's Knight only, who had come back to life.

"Oh, my Hell's Knight!"

Cannavaro shouted, almost pleading, once again. The yelling prompted Hell's Knight to pull its sword. Javier, on the other hand, had his sword

already aimed at Hell's Knight. A second later, a fight began without any noise.

"...!"

Boom! The shockwaves of their clash swept the whole area, and everyone on the floor was thrown away like a leaf. Javier and Hell's Knight neared each other only to become distant. And they hurtled toward each other again.

Thud! Kaboom!

Javier lifted his long sword with his arms and laid it horizontally above his head, his wrists moving at a mysterious angle. Its front blade quickly drew a half-circle, and the flash of light swished as it aimed at the side of Hell's Knight's head.

Clang!

Hell's Knight's grand sword defended Javier's long sword, creating a repulsive force. But Javier smartly used that force to his advantage and transferred it to his sword, his two overhead wrists moving again at a strange angle. And his right hand then rotated clockwise as the left hand was used as an axis. The sword rotated as it drew an arc above the head. And this time, Javier used the back of his blade to attack the other side of his opponent's head.

"...!"

Hell's Knight immediately jerked its head back, and the silvery aura sliced a portion of its helmet. It then laid a counterattack right after, its black sword sweeping across the space with overwhelming technique and skill.

Thwack!

Its blade was brought down so fiercely that the floor snapped, the pillar shook, and the ridgepole cracked. A countless number of shards flew around

at fatal speed, mostly toward Javier. But some of them flew toward the citizens. Javier snapped his eyes open.

“...!”

Clash! Slash!

His long silvery sword swung and slashed through the air like greased lightning, and the hundreds of shards turned to powder. Javier hurtled right through the powder, still drifting in the air. His long silvery sword acted as a fang from that moment.

Thud! Twang! Thwack!

If the long sword was a fatal fang, Hell’s Knight’s sword was a deadly gun. The sword master and knight from hell rushed at each other with an unreserved desire to end one another, and the scene was likened to a white and black beast chomping at each other. And like the relentless battle between the light and darkness, Javier and Hell’s Knight charged, focusing on each other and nothing else. Javier pierced, and Hell’s Knight stabbed. Hell’s Knight swung down, Javier charged forward. *Smack, charge. Charge, evade. Evade, smite. Smite, uppercut.*

Boooom!

The black sword cut downward, and the silver longsword defended upward. Those two deadly weapons collided in the air once again, blocking each other’s forces. With that, shockwaves burst out without reservation. And yet, neither one of them retreated. Frozen to the ground, they continued their power struggle.

Clang! Clang!

The black sword shoved downward, and the long silvery sword endured against it. A fierce friction took place as the two faced one another. Their gazes locked as embers burned and splattered from their blades. The glow inside Hell’s Knight’s eyes burned redder.

“You are strong, human.”

“...”

“I am Giolexius, the commander of the First Corps, and I serve the Master of Hell. How wonderful it would have been had my body been fully intact. But still, this fight has truly gone above my expectations. Therefore, I wish to inquire about your name, human knight.”

“Javier Asrahan,” replied Javier.

“Nice to meet you, Sir Asrahan. I ask that you do more and fight harder.”

“Whew. Although, I do not welcome fights like this.”

This power struggle where no effort was to be spared... Javier blurted as their blades touched each other. Hell’s Knight cocked its skull.

“How so?”

“No one welcomes a burdensome fight.”

Javier smirked cynically, thinking how ridiculous he sounded. But he was being honest. No one in this world welcomed a burdensome fight. If he could, he would simply avoid it. But the situation called for him to face forward and fight. That was why he remained there. Even so, however, it was a struggle. Hell’s Knight was gradually getting more forceful in its grip as it pressed its sword. He was in a frightening situation.

Will I be able to protect the people at this rate?

Javier was concerned. He looked at the people around him. They were thrown and sent to all corners of the hall when shockwaves came at them in series. No one looked to be okay enough to stand on their own. In other words, no one was capable of leaving this place on their own. So, there was only one thing left for Javier. Fight and win. That was the only way to protect the people here.

Like this!

Thwack!

Javier momentarily lowered the end of his long sword, and a slope appeared following the downward movement. Hell's Knight, who was pressing down on his sword, slid as the angle shifted, creating fierce sparks.

"...!"

Hell's Knight's eyes shook. Even before it was able to adjust to the shift in strength, its sword slipped sideways, and Javier used the chance to lift his right hand. A dagger was in his hand.

Kaboom! Mana blast jetted out from the dagger, aiming at its chin.

"Argh...!"

Hell's Knight jerked its head back at a tremendous speed. Then it proceeded to make its next move and fight.

Crash! It rammed into Javier with its shoulder, and to him, the blow felt like a large rock bashing him. And when Javier and Hell's Knight were about to start another beastly battle, there came a sound.

"Over there! Look at me!"

A piercing shout interrupted the fight. It was Cannavaro.

Slam! The long blade and black sword were still clashing together in the air, and Javier stole a glance sideways and scanned the area where the shout came from. What he witnessed shook him. Cannavaro, the once-respectable man in the city for his philanthropic deeds, the man that once surprised Javier for being exemplary, was held hostage.

"If you want to continue this fight," Cannavaro bawled, "you might want to think it again! Put down your sword! Or I will behead all these pests one by one!"

Cannavaro smirked slyly and grabbed a man's hair. Holding a dagger in his other hand, Cannavaro lightly pierced the man's neck. A streak of blood

dripped from his neck. And a girl, who was still lying on the ground, whimpered aloud.

“Papaaa!”

“Argh... Eek! I-I am fine. I am fine,” said the man, trying hard to calm his daughter even when his neck was covered in blood.

“I’m fine, my ass,” Cannavaro scoffed, “and shut your mouth unless you want to be beheaded.”

“Arggh...!”

The dagger moved slightly. More blood came out of his neck. Cannavaro’s eyes moved to Javier.

“See that? I’m going to count to three. I’m giving you time to think. And if you still don’t put your sword down, this girl will see her father’s throat get slit.”

“...”

Javier didn’t answer. He wordlessly resumed the fierce battle against Hell’s Knight, but he didn’t tear his eyes from the hostage situation completely. Cannavaro put on a twisted smile, pleased that Javier was in agony.

So, throw that sword away! Now!

Cannavaro was convinced that Javier would put down the sword. Why? He was a renowned knight in the kingdom. A rising star, and a sword master.

Isn’t that true, Sir Javier Asrahan?

A knight of such popularity would certainly value his reputation. So, he wouldn’t be able to easily give up on the hostages. Eventually, he would succumb and accept defeat. That was what mattered to Cannavaro at the moment.

Then I’ll get rid of him right away and restore the wall.

The wall could be restored and mana could be accumulated again. If he scraped all the life out of the citizens, he could fix Hell's Knight to be in perfect shape. Nearly all the kingdom's territories could be wiped out during the one month its summoning lasted. If forces came to fight, Hell's Knight could smash them. It would be a breeze for Hell's Knight as long as it was fully equipped. Decapitating the queen would even be possible. And that would be his dream come true, his dream to establish a new royal family as the current one was full of hypocrisy.

So, throw that sword away! Now!

Cannavaro glared at Javier, his gaze growing more intense. Then he got ready to make his next move. Once Javier put down the sword, he would slice this pest and help Hell's Knight by using the moment of shock to cast dark magic on him. Left without his sword, he would helplessly be defeated... Just then...

Kaboom! A mana blast was fired in Cannavaro's direction.

"...!"

Cannavaro snapped his eyes open in terror. At that moment, he finally realized what had just happened.

That fool!

Javier didn't throw the sword. Instead, he silently fired a terrible attack.

Arggh!

Cannavaro's heart pounded. Left with no time to think, he instinctively flopped to the ground backward and held out both of his hands to cast a defense spell.

Boom! But the mana blast was faster. Before his defense magic could be fully activated, it broke the magic apart and slayed the end of his index and middle fingers. And then it resumed its course to blast and penetrate the public hall.

“Argh!!!!!!”

Cannavaro rolled on the floor as he clutched his injured hand. Javier’s eyes drooped in disappointment.

“Tsk.”

Javier had aimed at the heart but failed because he was currently in a breathtaking fight against Hell’s Knight. He had fired the mana blast in a split moment, but his aim was missed. He failed to kill the warlock. Just sliced some fingers. Wistful of the result, Javier became anxious.

I should have finished him in one blow just now.

The price of failing to do so was high in two ways. First, Cannavaro would now be watching out for any mana blasts. That meant it’d be impossible to resolve the hostage situation by using the same method. Second, it was...

Boom!

“Argh...!”

Javier blocked the sword with some struggle. A bitter smile formed on his face.

I’m not sure I can win against him even after giving it my all.

When Javier fired the mana blast to suppress Cannavaro in between the fierce exchange of offense and defense, he had to ignore Hell’s Knight for a moment, and that broke the equal balance in their fight. That was the second price he had to pay.

Slam! Kaboom! Whack!

He aimed the mana blast in a different direction and wasted his energy with it. Because of that, the offense was now entirely in the hands of Hell’s Knight. It went the same for movement. Breathing and flow. The direction of the offense. The advantage of timing was now given to Hell’s Knight,

and it was hard to get it back because the Knight began launching an unreserved amount of attacks once it realized that the ball was in its hand.

Clang! Thud! Kaboom!

Smack, break, penetrate, wham, and grind. Instead of resorting to small techniques, Hell's Knight relied on its sheer strength and force. Such destructive attacks pushed Javier to the corner of the public hall as he couldn't find any time to counterattack. One thoughtless attempt and he'd be losing more than what he gained. That was how destructive and thorough its offenses were. The situation, moreover, gradually turned for the worse.

"Wahahaha! Hahaha! You! You thought that would work?!"

Cannavaro got back on his feet, and he picked up the dagger as his sliced fingers continued to bleed hard. He then once again grabbed the fugitive's head and put the dagger near his neck. This time, he used the man as his shield.

"Now, I'm ordering you again! Put down the sword!"

His vile shout echoed loudly in the public hall. Javier, who was barely holding up after being cornered, put on a dark expression. It was impossible to use the mana blast in his current situation. And putting down his sword was surely going to make Hell's Knight slash him in half.

What do I do?

Javier's eyes trembled. Watch the fugitive die to keep fighting? Throw away the sword to save the hostage first? Javier was dismayed as he could not judge what the right decision was. Of course, he knew continuing the fight was a gain for him. But he felt massively burdened to make that decision. There was the man, bleeding in the neck in the hands of Cannavaro. And there was his daughter crying as she watched her poor father. And there was him, a selfish knight debating whether to fight or not.

What do I-

Javier’s lips turned pale. Cannavaro smiled as he could see his victory was near.

“I’m going to count to five!”

Javier’s shoulders flinched. In a hurrying gaze, he looked at Cannavaro.

Wait a minute.

“Three!” Cannavaro yelled.

Please.

“Two!”

Stop.

“On-”

Bam! All of a sudden, there came a clear sound from the back of Cannavaro’s head, and his shout immediately halted at the same time.

“Eh...?”

His eyes rolled backward. His body staggered. His legs gave way. And when he flopped to the ground, it revealed a figure. Lloyd. He was holding his metal shovel, which he had just wielded in full swing. And he shrugged as he scoffed at Javier.

“Lady Ella, do you need a hand?”

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Chapter 175: Shoulder to Shoulder (1)

Bam! A clear, pure sound resounded throughout the whole area, and Cannavaro's eyes reversed.

Eek...?

His head hurt. The floor and ceiling pounded, and his world suddenly grew low. No, it was his body that did so. Even the cold flooring that touched his face felt distant and bleak.

What just...

Cannavaro thought of getting back to his feet. So, he desperately wiggled his body and fumbled on the ground. But that was as far as he could get.

Thwack! Once more, there came a clear ringing noise.

Ack.

That was one last shout before Cannavaro passed out. And someone scoffed above his fallen body.

"Goodness, this man's surprisingly tenacious."

Lloyd looked down at Cannavaro as he shook his head. What a tenacious man. Lloyd never imagined that the latter would writhe in agony and try to get up after getting knocked out by his blow on the head.

"Oh, well," drawled Lloyd, "I just need to hit you one more time. Anyway."

Lloyd lifted his head and looked toward Javier.

"Want some help, Lady Ella?"

But Javier didn't answer. It was because he couldn't. He was barely enduring the full brunt of Hell's Knight's focused attacks. But he managed

to send a welcoming gaze toward Lloyd, who immediately picked up the hint.

“Okay. I’ll take care of things here and go there right away. Hold on a little longer,” said Lloyd.

Lloyd knew that eliminating a source of future trouble was the first priority, and he had to completely suppress this menacing warlock. With such a thought in mind, Lloyd looked back.

“Ggoming,” called Lloyd.

“Ggoming!”

Ggoming, who got here with Lloyd, answered from the loft of the public hall when Lloyd called. A large parrotbill spread his wings to glide down.

“You know what to do, right?”

“Ggoming!”

Lloyd didn’t have to spell out his plan. All he did was point at Cannavaro pinned to the ground. Ggoming then gave his bag a shake.

Pssh!!! A spider web that was sturdier and stronger than metal was discharged from his bag, tying up Cannavaro’s hands, shackling his legs, and coiling his body up. Like a spider tying its game in the wild, Ggoming tightly bound Cannavaro, even more firmly than 30 layers of bubble wrap. Just like that, the warlock was completely suppressed. But Lloyd didn’t stop there.

“Hey, man.”

Lloyd helped the man breathing on the ground beside Cannavaro. Wiping the blood off his neck, Lloyd spoke.

“Can you move?”

“A-a little bit...” The man nodded with some struggle. “Aren’t you Master Lloyd? Nice to meet you, my lord...”

“I knew it. I knew I wasn’t mistaken. You visited my fiefdom with Lady Namaran, didn’t you?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, my lord.”

“Then I suppose you can heal faster than the rest of the people here.”

“Sure... Eek.”

The knight sucked in a breath at the abrupt entrance of mana into his body when Lloyd placed his hand on the knight’s shoulder.

“Woah. No need to be surprised. I’m putting some mana into your body, so you can get well.”

“But why...” murmured the knight.

“Why else?” asked Lloyd as he glanced around the hall. “Do you see the people around you?”

“Yes.”

“Take them outside. I fear it’s going to get messier from now on.”

“Yes.”

An elaborate explanation was unnecessary as the knight had watched the entire situation unfold from the beginning. Thankfully, no one was severely hurt by the shards of rocks or the shockwaves. However, there was no guarantee that luck would always be on everyone’s side like this. The knight raised his body, and it looked like Lloyd’s Asrahan Core Technique did a lot to restore much of his energy. Carrying his daughter, a nearby old woman, and a middle-aged man altogether, the knight spoke.

“Please be careful, my lord, I shall come and help fight soon.”

“I don’t expect you to,” dismissed Lloyd. “Move the people out of here. I gave you mana for that job, not to fight.”

“Yes... My Lord.”

“Hurry up.”

“Y-yes.”

The knight hurriedly moved, carrying people out of the public hall. Ggoming helped out in the effort as he strutted around and fluttered his short wings. It was only then that Lloyd sighed in relief.

“Whew.”

The surroundings were organized somewhat. Fighting can take without any concern for casualties. Lloyd grabbed his metal shovel in relief, and in his other hand, he grasped Cannavaro’s head.

“Let’s get started.”

Dragging Cannavaro with his one hand, Lloyd walked over to the center of the public hall. Javier and Hell’s Knight. He moved toward the very place where this transcendental fight was taking place. A look of confusion appeared on Lloyd’s face.

Wow. How did I come this far?

It was a match between two transcendental figures. Lloyd’s shoulders flinched as he watched Javier and Hell’s Knight blast shockwaves in the midst of their fight. Lloyd hated fighting. He never enjoyed it. Yes, originally, he was no one other than Suho Kim, an average fellow living in South Korea. So, what happened? How did he get involved in this fight?

Duh. I’m doing this for money.

It was too late to return to his old, ordinary lifestyle. No, he didn’t even have the desire to go back. Once he reached that conclusion, Lloyd grasped the metal shovel and sought the best timing. Right when Hell’s Knight was

about to pummel Javier with great force, he lifted his shovel up and aimed at Cannavaro’s head. Determined, he shouted aloud.

“Over there! Hell’s Knight! Stop moving! Or else he dies!”

Lloyd’s yelling, which was charged with mana, effortlessly pierced Hell’s Knight’s skull.

“...!”

Lloyd’s inference created a tiny room for an attack on Hell’s Knight, which was wielding its sword so powerfully. And Javier was no fool to miss it.

Thwack! Clang!

The silvery long sword cut out a brilliant ray of light, parrying the black sword in one stroke. This thankfully allowed Javier to slip out from the unceasing offense of its opponent without harm and finally manage to maintain some distance and catch his breath for the first time Hell’s Knight had the upper hand. But Hell’s Knight was looking somewhere else, and it didn’t even look wistful. Instead, it turned and looked at Lloyd with dismay.

“What?”

Hell’s Knight glared at Lloyd in disbelief. Lloyd flinched instinctively when he received the hellish gaze, but he gathered his thoughts and looked straight at it.

“Can’t hear me?” asked Lloyd. “I thought I said it loud and clear! Wait, is your hearing bad because you’re a skeleton?”

“What is it that you want to say...?”

“Come on, I told you. I’ll kill this man if you don’t stop attacking.”

“Is this a fugitive situation? Against me?”

“Yeah.”

Lloyd nodded his head like it was obvious, so confidently that he seemed to say, “You’re done for!”

“This one summoned you, didn’t he? He dies, and you’ll be transported back to Hell. Come on, did you think I didn’t know about that?”

It was true. Cannavaro was the one who summoned it to this earth. It was he who marked the sculpture with his blood. And that shamanistic symbol was used as a means for Hell’s Knight to get here. So, if Cannavaro died, the summoning would stop as Hell’s Knight was brought here by the blood of Cannavaro.

“It’s simple. It’s exactly like taking a loan from a bank. Cannavaro put down the security, and he issued the certificate of proof with his own blood. That was how he allowed your arrival. But what if... Cannavaro, your security, dies? What do you think will happen to you?” asked Lloyd.

It was very simple. If the security was gone, the document was no more useful than tissue paper. Then the loan process would be a moot thing. That was the way it was.

“So, give up that scary sword and surrender. That is if you want to stay a little longer in this world, unlike Hell.”

Lloyd’s confident threat rang aloud the hall. Hell’s Knight was dismayed.

“Ha. How dare you. Tell me, are you not from this world?”

“What?”

“Your words and actions befit Hell, no matter how I look at it. Did you get banished from Hell and put on a cover as a human?”

“Not at all. You’re completely off-base.”

“Is that so? Anyway, I see your point. But you are missing something.”

“I’m missing something?” asked Lloyd.

“Indeed.”

“What could that be?”

“That human can die, but I can still stay here for an hour before I get transported back.”

“What?”

At that moment, Hell’s Knight lifted its sword, its movement frightfully swift and abrupt. The energy of death discharged out of its blade was like a tsunami and passed through the air to claim Lloyd’s life.

“...!”

Lloyd leaped midair as he tugged Cannavaro wrapped up in a spider web. He closely managed to avoid the blow, only to see the black sword charge down at him.

“I will slice you in half along with my human summoner.”

“Huh?”

Swooosh! Its sword cut the air and swung down. It was too fast and hostile. Lloyd couldn’t dare block it with his shovel. No, it came down too rapidly that he couldn’t find the time to do so. Had it not for the silvery long sword that intervened, Lloyd would have been sliced in half.

Thwack!

“...!”

A long sword suddenly came into view, blocking the black blade, ready to end his life. Then it parried the sword away.

Clang! Lloyd feared that his entire eardrum would burst. The banging noise threw Lloyd to the ground.

“Argh!”

“Get back on your feet. If you want to live.”

Javier icily spoke in Lloyd’s ears. Lloyd immediately jumped to his feet without thinking and grabbed his shovel and fixed his posture. Shoulder to shoulder, Javier and Lloyd stood as they faced Hell’s Knight, who stood ramrod straight.

Whoosh...

Lloyd unconsciously gulped, finally registering how formidable Hell’s Knight was. The aura and energy that it gave off became so evident as he stood face to face. It was terrifying even when it was without its horse and lacked an arm and leg.

Goodness, it feels like a novice gamer got involved in a battle between masters.

Chills ran down his spine. Every part of his body tensed up. His grip that grasped the shovel became wet with sweat. He never planned on getting so deeply involved in the fight. He simply wanted to use some trickery and shoot the mana blast at this hellish creature from afar.

“It appears that it regarded you as my weakness.”

Javier’s voice was stern.

“I know,” awkwardly smiled Lloyd. “It looks like it did.”

Hell’s Knight will lay a concentrated attack on me, Lloyd thought, and Javier will put himself in harm’s way to protect me.

That’s how it’s going to create a weakness. I’m a crack in a dam, and it’s going to focus on the crack. Just like how a small hole can cause a dam to collapse. It plans to take care of us both at once.

Hell’s Knight became plain and evident to Lloyd. But it was too late to give up and leave.

“Do not step back so hastily. You are now in its offense range. The moment you half-heartedly try to back down, you’ll be done for in less than a second,” warned Javier.

“I know. I know that too,” Lloyd smiled awkwardly

“Then apologize.”

“For what?” huffed Lloyd.

“For calling me Lady Ella just a while ago.”

“Okay. I’m sorry. I’m apologizing. You’re a good boy, Javier, aren’t you?”

“...”

“Now, what? What do you want me to do?” asked Lloyd as he stole his glance at Javier.

“Endure.”

“What?”

“It’s coming.”

Right after that moment...

Whoosh! Lloyd wondered if this was what it felt like to take the full blow of a storm. Hell’s Knight hurtled forward after leaping up with one leg. And it brandished, no, swept its huge sword to the side.

Argh...!

Sensing that facing it head-on would get him sliced in half with him and his shovel, he instead rushed toward the incoming sword. He then stretched his shovel and shot the most powerful blow he could manage. A triple mana blast. *Kaboom!*

“...!”

His triple mana blast boasted an amazing power for a split second. Such an unexpected burst of power squarely collided with the incoming sword. But the latter wasn't affected. It instead slashed the triple mana blast force abreast and made its way further in.

Slash! Its sword sliced the triple mana blast in half, but it failed to cut Lloyd in half as it grew minutely weaker to slice the pressure of the triple mana blast. Lloyd used that opportunity to roll to the ground.

"Now!"

Lloyd yelled as he rolled under the incoming sword and held out both of his hands to hug the knight's pelvis and leg. That toppled, though very minimal, off its balance. Javier's long sword glinted ferociously just then.

Bam! His aura-charged long sword penetrated into the giant sword almost half, and Hell's Knight tried to shake Lloyd off its leg. But it couldn't do so as Javier started to lay into it without giving a moment to spare.

Thud! Twang! Thwack!

"...!"

Underneath was a human that was glued to it like a leech. Above was a determined knight who overpowered a sword master. Hell's Knight's gaze trembled. The situation turned for the worse for Hell's Knight as Lloyd began uttering mysterious, shamanistic chants as he clutched its leg.

"You are! You are born to be loved! And in this life of yours! You are loved!"

"...!"

Its gaze trembled some more. Its upper torso received the full brunt of Javier's swords, and its lower body was tortured by Lloyd, who continued to sing exotic songs. And these two discordant attacks doubled its agony. What was worse was that there was just no end to these contrasting attacks. *Rattle! Rattle! Rattle!*

Javier began to go all out in his attacks as the opportunity finally presented itself to him. And Lloyd's medley of exorcism chants became more diverse.

"Mahayana! Paramita! Sutra! Avalokitesvara! Prajna Paramita! Trayaya! Kamkani! Sutraaaa!"

"Argh...!"

What kind of bizarre sorcery was that? Hell's Knight was thrown into greater confusion. Of course, there was no direct damage from the songs. But its mind and spirit were utterly disturbed and confused. It was already receiving the full offense from Javier, and that alone demanded its full attention and power.

But this human that had latched himself on its one leg was singing this eerie incantation to his heart's content. Hell's Knight was on the verge of losing it. And how out-of-tune he was! Hell's Knight wondered if this was what it felt like to hear nails scratching a chalkboard or cicadas crying right into its ear. What was more than its noise was the discordant tunes. Yes, that was right. Lloyd was the worst tone-deaf, the worst kind that even Hell's Knight would be sickened of.

"Stop...!"

Finally, no longer able to endure any longer, Hell's Knight violently shook its head and leaped in the air with Lloyd still latched onto its leg. It was how much it wanted to wrench him off its feet. But that turned out to be a mistake.

Slash!

"...!"

It lost focus in a split second, and Javier's aura-charged silvery-long sword penetrated Hell's Knight's skull.

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Chapter 176: Shoulder to Shoulder (2)

Slash! The aura-charged long sword radiated light, penetrating Hell's Knight's skull with the force of a lightning bolt. At that moment...

"...!"

Hell's Knight was leaping in the air, and its sword moved. *Boom!*

The sword swept through the space above it, right where Javier's blade came down. But its sword didn't overlap with the latter's trajectory. Was it because it missed? No.

It's aimed at Javier.

Lloyd's eyes flew open. Glued to its leg, Lloyd could see the whole thing just by lifting his head. And that was how he was able to see through Hell's Knight's intentions.

That monster is trying to die with Javier.

It appeared that it didn't intend to prevent its skull from getting pierced. Instead, it was trying to make use of that opportunity and grind his body whole. Lloyd immediately racked his brain posthaste and deliberated on the direction this fight must take onward.

I have a bad feeling about this.

Hell's Knight and Javier. What if they left fatal injuries to one another? Javier would be the only victim here. Hell's Knight would be relatively fine. Then left all alone, Lloyd would become its next prey.

I have to stop it!

Javier's long sword and Hell's Knight's sword. They were already charging toward their targets. The former toward the Hell's Knight's skull. The latter toward Javier's body. At the very moment they almost stabbed and slayed,

Lloyd lifted both hands and grabbed his enemy's ribs revealed under its breastplate as though he was grabbing a metal bar. The Asrahan Core Technique, manaheart, and elbow and back muscles. He tugged as powerfully as he could, as though he was doing a pull-up.

Ack!!!

Crack! The Knight's torso was lightly pulled, and its movement shook for a split second less than one millimeter to the side. But that tiny difference changed the sword's trajectory.

Fwoosh! The grand sword sliced through the air but missed its target, and Javier twisted his body and held out his long sword up to the end.

Slash!

"...!"

Javier's long sword finally pierced its skull, and Hell's Knight jerked terribly at the blow. But as though it wasn't ready to give up yet, as though it was going to struggle for the last time, it wielded its sword as it twisted and turned its whole body, bent on destroying everything within its range. Javier didn't move back as well. Instead, he danced to its tune, and, in a magnificent burst of movement, he wielded his long sword to stab and slash Hell's Knight at every given chance. Each time he did so, the latter's body shook visibly. Lloyd joined in on the effort as he tightly hugged its pelvis and leg. After limiting its movement with his arms and legs like a cicada, Lloyd made innovative use of a weapon he could freely use. It was his mouth.

"Give me peace! Give me peace! Give me peace, peace, peace! Give me! Peace! Peaceee!"

Lloyd sang at the top of his lungs, reviving the memories he was in the military and recalling the times he used to follow his mother to the temple. Every Christian and Buddhist lyric he could remember was brought to use. His throat jerked heavily as he fired the ammunition of exorcist songs. But

technically speaking, what came out of his tongue was more like a flood of discordant melody.

“May I be free from anger! Homage to him, the Gracious, the Exalted! Emptiness is nothing other than form! May I take care of myself and be happy! All dharmas are marked with emptiness!”

Lloyd sang, struggling with all of his might. Tunes were out, and his voice turned hoarse often. But it wasn’t intentional, of course. He was pretty serious about hitting the right tune. But the heavens didn’t bestow an iota of singing ability to him though it gave him the gift of studying. So yes, Lloyd was a horrible singer. The worst kind of all.

Dammit. I’m not... doing this because I want to, okay?!

Putting every ounce of his might and soul into singing, Lloyd recalled a past event. It must have been when he was a private. Singing gave him a massively hard time. Whenever everyone went out for a morning run, his senior ranks reamed him out for being a terrible singer. His singing was anything but acceptable, even when cadence hardly placed importance on getting the tones right. That wasn’t the only occasion. For a period of time, Lloyd regularly attended church for the first time in his life to eat the moon pie they handed out. But he wasn’t welcomed there. On the day he attended the church service and sang the hymn, Lloyd attracted a lot of glares due to his unforgivable singing. It was the case even though he had sung with quite an effort. The chaplain was flabbergasted by him.

He shot me a look as if I was a devil who descended on earth! His gaze is still clear in my head!

But that wasn’t all. There was another heartbreaking incident. It must have been right after coming back to school after his leave of absence. That marked the one and only time he had dated a girl in school. But one day, they headed to a karaoke room together, and as a result, they broke up the next day.

Okay, this is making me sad. Let’s stop thinking about this.

Lloyd decided to admit it. I am a horrible singer, he told himself. But that wasn't something to be ashamed of. Sometimes, that lack of skill can be used as a weapon!

Like now! Time to chant Thousand Eyes and Hands Sutra!

Lloyd's mind traveled back to his childhood days when he went up to a temple, her mother's hand in his. And the chant the monk had read aloud called to his mind. A flash of determination appeared in his eyes. From then on...

"Time for some mantra clean verbal karma!Suri Suri Mahasuri Susuri Savaha!"

Lloyd's voice, filled with distrust, started to echo through the land with more determination. That caused Hell's Knight to be massively disturbed.

"Stop...!"

Stop it, you animal!

Hell's Knight wanted to beg for real. It was already hard enough with this silver-haired knight alone, but this weirdo stuck to its leg was singing songs that even the devils would grow sick of. Moreover, his voice was terribly loud and high-pitched that his skull pierced with the sword would crack open. No, it actually was happening right now in real-time. It didn't have enough time to recover from the stabbing blow of Javier. And the consecutive blows that followed broke, smashed, and damaged Hell's Knight. And at last...

"Master Lloyd, now!"

Javier yelled, and an aura-charged mana blast burst out at the same time. Lloyd stopped singing at that moment, letting go of its pelvis and leg. And then he jerked to the side, the mana blast sweeping over him right then and attacking the upper torso of Hell's Knight.

"...!"

Kaboom! Hell’s Knight’s armor melted. Its sword moved forward for protection, its bones that gripped the sword and whole torso, everything got rampaged by the mana blast from the aura. Everything melted, crumbled, turned into powder, and vanished in thin air.

Clack! Its lower torso, which was barely left intact, shook. Its one knee went down, staggered to the side. Its joints snapped.

Crash... Now turned into powder, the upper torso vanished in thin air, and its lower torso was destroyed. A strange silence gripped the public hall. Lloyd, who had flung himself to the side, caught his breath and stood up.

W-we got it.

Lloyd internalized what he and Javier just did. The two of them had defeated Hell’s Knight. Just then...

“It is too early to be relieved,” Javier said. “It’s going to come back to life again.”

Javier spoke with a stern expression on his face. He even had his sword pointed at the pile of bones.

“Come back to life? Like a resurrection?” asked Lloyd in a daze.

“I don’t know. But...” Javier quickly replied to Lloyd. “It was like this before. Before you came, I killed it. But it came back to life completely intact and free of harm.”

“Hold on,” said Lloyd, “That means-”

“Its mana is still here.”

“...”

It was actually true. Lloyd could feel a large volume of mana in the pile of bones of its lower torso through using the Asrahan Core Technique. Nothing was gone. But that wasn’t all.

A large volume of mana is being held together in the air.

The bones that got crushed into powder after taking Javier's mana blast were drifting in the air. Lloyd could sense powerful mana coming from there as well.

What the heck?

His hair rose. The fact that the mana lingered in the air meant that Hell's Knight was still alive.

This is not good. That's right. The novel mentioned a similar thing as well.

Just then, Lloyd was reminded of a story in the novel. It was about what Cannavaro said right before the Namaran's Wall incident took place.

Cannavaro was confident that everything would be over once he summoned Hell's Knight. Yeah. He said that it's extremely powerful and endlessly revives since the creature is from Hell. I think it said that Hell's Knight can come back to life even after its bones become reduced to powder.

That was how persistent Hell's Knight was. And at the same time, the novel briefly mentioned the method to defeat it.

The only viable method is to deplete its mana. That was why Cannavaro brimmed with confidence. Honestly, it's understandable. To exhaust mana, one has to severely beat an object until it's left without any strength or absorb mana using a special magic spell or instrument.

Who in the world could render Hell's Knight to such a state? And what instrument or magic could absorb such a massive load of mana out of Hell's Knight? It was possible only in theory, and the world had no person, instrument, or magic that could do so. Therefore, the fictional Cannavaro ascertained that Hell's Knight was close to being invincible. In other words...

That goes the same right now.

Judging by what Javier said, it looked like Hell’s Knight was indeed capable of endlessly coming back to life.

“I will take care of it,” said Lloyd with finality in his voice.

“What?”

Javier turned to Lloyd, his eyes bulging in surprise, and it made Lloyd grin at the sight. It reflected very well how caring and worried Javier could be during critical moments, even though he acted grouchy about almost everything on most days.

“I will take care of it. You know it, too, right? What I am capable of,” Lloyd said.

“Do you mean the indiscriminate mana absorption?”

“Uh-huh.”

Supercharge. That was what they needed right now. Lloyd and Javier had to exhaust all the mana out of Hell’s Knight. Otherwise, they would have to take care of him every time he came back to life, and so, there was nothing as effective as the Supercharge skill to stop it altogether.

“So, step back, and make sure no one comes near.”

“Master Lloyd.”

“I know, I’m worried as well. Scared, too.”

Lloyd was scared. But he chuckled instead as he faced Javier, who was wearing a worrisome expression on his face.

“I am sure you will know as well. I don’t particularly enjoy overeating,” quipped Lloyd.

“Will you be all right?”

“I have to be. To be frank with you, I don’t like it either. But I don’t see any other alternative. My stomach will hurt, I fear, but I’ll do whatever I can now.”

Lloyd playfully shrugged his shoulders, and he was actually worried. In all seriousness, he was about to absorb Hell’s Knight’s mana. Lloyd wondered if he would be all right after indiscriminately absorbing its mana. When he thought so, a sense of resignation rushed through him as it looked absolutely outrageous. He was averse to the idea and scared.

But we’re going to die if I don’t do this. Javier can’t deal with Hell’s Knight forever, even if it’s him. The same goes for me. And for this city.

The chance to subdue Hell’s Knight was here, and he had to take it. It could never appear again. Everyone would be done for if he blew this chance, including him.

So, it’s do or die now. I die if I don’t do this, and I die if I fail. But if I succeed, I live.

There was no other alternative. He had to give it a try. Biting his lips, Lloyd stepped forward to the crushed lower torso of Hell’s Knight. He collected his breath and got ready.

“Step back.”

Javier stood back. And without any hesitation, Lloyd grabbed the metal shovel.

Boom! The full-blown triple mana blast penetrated the ceiling of the public hall, pushing his stamina and bringing a terrible pang of dizziness. Lloyd opened the skill window as he fought faint nausea. And he selected the optional skill.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option ⑤: Supercharge has been activated.]

[You are randomly absorbing a large amount of mana from your surroundings.]

From that moment, the three-stranded mana circles roared as they began to suck every mana around the place. It took in everything in its way, the marble flooring, the rolling specks of dust, Hell's Knight's leg, the bone powders in the air, and the mana. Everything was engulfed and absorbed. Nothing wasn't discriminated against. Both those that are easy to absorb and that are not, the pure and the impure were all absorbed. The suction power usurped, exploited, and stole everything around it. If Hell's Knight was summoned with all parts intact and didn't remain in such a vulnerable state, it would've been able to cope with it and resist the Supercharge. But not now. It was summoned with defects. It had been defeated and remained vulnerable.

"...!"

As the suctioning power rampaged the whole area, Hell's Knight, Sir Giolexius, the Corps Commander of Hell, screamed as it perished. That was the end of it. And later...

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option ⑤: Your Supercharge time is up.]

The rampaging mana absorption was over. The roaring mana circle calmed down. Lloyd slowly opened his eyes, and his eyes noticed a host of messages floating in the air.

[You have eliminated Hell's Knight, Sir Giolexius the Corps Commander under the King of Hell.]

[The King of Hell is impressed by your tremendous accomplishment. The King of Hell has lost his corps commander but now has his eyes on your skill, tact, and potential.]

[Moreover, a portion of the mana you have absorbed in abundance from Hell's Knight is yours.]

[This rare experience greatly influenced your skills and optional skills.]

[The 4th optional skill of the manaheart, “Zombie Domination,” has been separated to become an independent skill.]

[Zombie Domination skill has been upgraded.]

[Zombie Domination skill has been reinforced.]

[The various restrictions and conditions attached to Zombie Domination have largely been relaxed and eliminated.]

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Chapter 177: When Skeletons Pay Their Debts (1)

[The 4th optional skill of the manaheart, “Zombie Domination,” has been separated to become an independent skill.]

What?

Lloyd opened his eyes wide right after he used the Supercharge. He had risked himself using the skill to decisively end Hell’s Knight and succeeded in stopping its infinite resurrection power. It was either do or die. The first thing that crossed his mind when he opened his eyes was...

I’m alive.

Then he noticed the pleasing messages in front of him. What pleased him more than the content was that he could see the messages themselves. It at least meant that he didn’t die.

What happened to Hell’s Knight?

Lloyd quickly looked around like a kid sneaking into the kitchen trying to steal cookies from a cookie jar without getting caught by his mother.

It’s gone.

He couldn’t feel Hell’s Knight’s mana. The violent and evil energy was now completely gone. What it meant was clear. Hell’s Knight had been eliminated. It worked. Now relieved, Lloyd moved his gaze to the messages. Now that the crisis was overcome, it was time to reap the benefits and party. And like a fisherman gazing at a net full of fish, Lloyd read through the message.

[Zombie Domination skill has been upgraded.]

[Zombie Domination skill has been reinforced.]

[The various restrictions and conditions attached to Zombie Domination have largely been relaxed and eliminated.]

Oh!

Lloyd was off to a good start. He had a good feeling as well. His heart pounded in expectation. His eyes moved faster.

[Your manaheart has absorbed and processed the mana of Hell's Knight. But since you are a mortal, you cannot make all of it yours. However, a portion of the mana in your manaheart can now reverberate with the mana of the undead.]

[This characteristic has escalated your manaheart's optional skill, Zombie Domination, into an independent skill.]

[Skill Name: Zombie Domination]

[Stage: Basic Lv.1]

[You can dominate low-grade undead soldiers at a set scale. The undead soldiers under your domination will provide unconditional allegiance and faithfulness to you.]

[Types of undead soldiers you can dominate: zombies and skeletons.]

[The number of undead soldiers you can dominate: 200]

[The current number of undead soldiers under your domination: 0]

Wow.

Lloyd was agape after he read the skill. This was incredible. Was it because he could dominate undead soldiers?

No! I was given free laborers to use from now on!

His eyes glimmered. Now, he held 200 laborers who were extremely efficient. No pay. No rest. No mercy. These skeletons could shovel on and

on even under the harshest circumstances. And Lloyd didn’t have to feed them. Not even breakfast or anything else. And what about their lodging? Just 200 coffins that fit their bodies. That would allow them to find their own coffins and cover the lid and rest. Simply put, Lloyd earned 200 work robots that wouldn’t demand any wage or food.

Good. Covering the workers’ wages was getting out of hand.

A large grin hung on his face as he thought about it. Lloyd was a seasoned engineer who had completed a host of construction projects. And throughout his career, he never even once missed paying his workers. Regardless of the size of the construction, even if it meant emptying his own wallet, Lloyd dutifully ensured that his workers got paid. Come hell or high water. Given the depressing experiences he’d gone through back in Korea, how could he not?

I didn’t want to stoop down to their level and become trash.

Lloyd’s heart stung whenever he thought about unpaid labor. There was a time he had worked hard but failed to receive his wages. He would file a complaint to his managers, but it would only invite mockery and ignorance. The supervisors dismissed him, saying that he should stop acting like a rookie and that everyone has their own situation to consider. These employers acted brazenly that they, too, were in a difficult spot. Lloyd hated them for that. And that was the reason for it. Lloyd never wanted to repeat those disgusting deeds now stuck in his heart like a dagger. As such, Lloyd faithfully paid his workers the best he could when it came to their wages. There were times when he pushed himself beyond his limits to pay his workers. Coming to Namaran was one example. He decided to come here for the sole purpose of acquiring money to pay the workers.

Sure, there’s the side objective of preventing the Namaran’s Wall incident, but still.

Projects like the apartment complex and sewage system, which covered the entire fiefdom, required Lloyd to pay a large sum of money to the workers at the end of the year. That was why he came here and took on the slope stabilization project. But once everything was over and the wages were

given out without any issue, Lloyd wouldn’t have to worry about this anymore.

Now, I can use these undead soldiers for small construction projects. And I’ll team them up with some engineers. That’s going to let me cut down the labor costs by a good amount.

The engineering corps could supervise the scene and make sure everything happened according to plan. The undead soldiers would be in charge of the chores. Lloyd could see it happening in his head. But that wasn’t the last of his rewards. An additional message appeared.

Ding dong.

[You have participated in heroic combat to eliminate Hell’s Knight, the corps commander from Hell.]

[In the process, you have merited great credit in turning the table in hopeless combat by seriously damaging your opponent’s hearing.]

[Some of the citizens in Namaran city have witnessed and heard the scene of resolve, courage, and outrageous off-tune.]

[For this, a unique title of yours will spread throughout the city of Namaran.]

[You have earned a new title.]

[A new title <Hell’s Singer>.]

[Hell’s Singer]

[Title Level: Regional Epic Tale & Scary Story]

The Namaran’s Wall stood tall and high. People fell, crying out loud. Everyone searched for redemption when the silver-haired knight got to his feet. Combat he did against Hell’s Knight. But he was outpowered. The power of Hell was overcome, only to return. The silver-haired knight pleaded before the mysterious power. Who shall stand shoulder

to shoulder and fight with me? Who shall, with valor, come forward for everyone? I only seek one. Then someone called out. I want peace! Mahavanya Suri Suri Sabaha! Like a leech, the man clutched the Hell's Knight's leg. The thunderous voice plunged the Knight into doom. Stop it! Do not sing! No more noise, please! Those were the last words of Hell's Knight.

[Compliment Effect: You have become a celebrity among all existence, including the undead. You are now notorious for owning a devilish musical sense in this earth and hell. For this, every creature in this earth and hell will fear, or at times respect, your singing.]

[Title Region: Namaran County & Hell.]

[Active Period of Title: 80 years (Namaran County) / 30,000 years (Hell)]

[A title's powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region for which the compliment was given. Moreover, the time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 4]

[Current CP: 254]

"..."

Now, it was nationally acknowledged that Lloyd was a bad singer. No, since the region included Hell, his out-of-tune singing had become known globally and in another dimension.

It sucked that things ended badly with my crush just because I sang terribly, and now, this?! Right, Eunhyang?

Lloyd called the name of his former crush in his head bitterly, but no reply came back. Instead of her, Lloyd only saw Javier's gaze boring into him, completely oblivious to what was happening in the former's heart.

"...All right?" asked Javier.

“Huh?”

A hand waved through the messages, breaking Lloyd’s trance. It was Javier who was motioning his hand in front of Lloyd.

“Are you all right?” Javier asked again. His studious gaze seemed to be more discreet than usual, just a little bit.

“Wait, are you worried about me?” asked Lloyd as he chuckled.

To his surprise, Javier nodded without denial.

“Yes, I am worried about you.”

“The heck? Have you lost your mind?”

Javier’s honesty flabbergasted Lloyd.

“You. Who are you?” asked Lloyd in astonishment.

“...”

“Javier isn’t the type of person to do this. Be frank with me. Where did you hide my dear Javier? Did you kidnap him? Lock him up? Or tie him down? Is he alive?”

“I... was neither kidnapped nor locked away,” said Javier lightly.

“Then how? What change of attitude do you have to tell me that you’re worried about me? Do you have a favor to ask me?”

“No, of course not. But...”

Javier’s eyes grew serious.

“As I listened to your song, I became worried.”

“While you were listening to me sing?” inquired Lloyd, quite not following with Javier.

“Yes.”

“What about it?”

“Your melody and tune were hellish. Hearing them alone hurt my ears. I almost used the mana blast on you, not the skeleton knight. I was provoked.”

“Hey...” muttered Lloyd.

“That is why I am worried. Are you mentally all right? Has the warlock put horrible thoughts into your head without your knowledge?” asked Javier, every one of his words serious.

“Hey, I’m-”

“Are you,” Javier interrupted, “truly fine?”

“...”

Looking at his grim and serious gaze brought an onrush of bitterness in Lloyd’s heart. Biting the underlip hard, Lloyd retorted, “I am perfectly fine!”

“Do you really mean it?”

“Uh-huh.”

“But how do you explain such eerie singing then-”

“I tried my best,” huffed Lloyd as he cut in.

“Master Lloyd, then could you be-”

“Don’t go there.”

“Tone-deaf...”

“I said, don’t go there.”

“...”

The worrisome gaze vanished instantly to be replaced with regret and pity. Lloyd sighed. For almost a second there, he was touched by Javier’s surprising concern.

“Tsk,” replied Lloyd as he changed the subject. “Now’s not the time for that. Let’s move now. We need to check on the people, too. By the way, how about you? You all right?”

“Yes. I’m fine.”

“Let’s go then.”

“Yes.”

The joy of victory lasted only briefly as the noise outside the messy public hall brought them back to reality. The noise came from the people who had passed out after the wall usurped all of their mana. Lloyd and Javier collected their breaths, slowly activating the Asrahan Core Technique when they figured out the source of the noise. Then they turned toward the exit of the public hall. The situation was not yet over. People needed emergency treatment.

“In a situation like this, the Asrahan Core Technique will be effective,” said Javier.

“Yeah. Should we transfer the mana into them after absorbing the mana in the air?” asked Lloyd.

“It sounds like it will be a long and tiring day.”

“Yes, I agree.”

With faint smiles on their faces, they left the public hall.

***

The situation was taken care of with ease. And thankfully, no Namaran citizen died from this incident. It was because the wall that devoured people's mana was neutralized relatively early, so most people didn't lose mana to the point of losing their lives. But there were quite a number of those who were seriously worn out and exhausted. Lloyd and Javier focused on those people.

The Asrahan Core Technique specialized in absorbing and discharging mana, and that undoubtedly played a critical role. It saved the people who were dangerously mana-depleted. It awakened those who were passed out. It revitalized those who were barely holding on. And as for Cannavaro, he was moved to the palace like cargo, neutralized and incapacitated.

He'll probably be questioned in the palace. A team of the best of the best royal magicians will brainwash him to get a confession out of him. After all, Queen Magentano is merciless and unreserved when it comes to these matters. She's extremely blunt.

On the second night of straining themselves in treating people, Lloyd sank on the bed, dead tired as he pushed away his idle thoughts. But strangely, he couldn't fall asleep even when he was on the bed. Could it be because he was too tired? His body lay flat on the bed like a wet laundry, but his mind drifted back to thoughts that distracted him.

I envy you, Javier, in times like these.

Lloyd glanced at Javier, who was already sleeping well on the bed beside his. One lullaby, and that was all it took to put him to sleep. Lloyd was envious. He direly wanted to sleep, but it didn't allow him to. Instead, all sorts of thoughts and concerns continued to attack him.

Thankfully, the Namaran situation is over. And though Count Namaran is terribly worn out that he needs some days to rest, he's overall fine. Then nothing to worry about, I guess No, I don't think that's the case.

The Namaran situation was over after a tediously long process. But Lloyd continued to frown. Why? The reason was simple.

Sure, it's good that the situation is over, but construction-wise, it was a huge stumbling block.

It was true. Now that the people had lost great volumes of mana, they were wretchedly exhausted. They could walk around but needed time until they recovered enough energy to do any work that required strength.

You know, like work on construction sites.

Construction projects were laborious. They involved transferring heavy materials and shoveling, pickaxing, and hammering all day in both hot and cold environments. And those in charge of such tasks were the people of this city. In other words, those who were supposed to be put to construction needed to rest as they'd lost a large volume of energy.

They need to rest for at least 15 days to restore their energy. Shoot, I hate delaying construction schedules.

The slope stabilization project Lloyd had earned here in the city was almost done in design. The timing was perfect for forming a team and starting with the basic construction, but now, an unexpected labor issue raised his hackles.

I want to finish the construction fast. I want to earn a lot of money and go back home. I want to retire in my fiefdom without worrying about money.

He wished that the undead soldiers would show up now. That would allow him to mobilize the laborers using the zombie domination skill.

It's not like I can dig graves now.

He couldn't, and that frustrated him. The Zombie Domination skill was a good skill, except for the part where getting his hands on the undead soldiers was a bit tricky.

Should I learn dark magic or something? I'm too lazy to bother with that. I don't want to, either. Oh, what the heck. Let's just sleep.

Lloyd tossed and turned in his bed. Enough with thoughts and concerns. It was time to sleep as he was tired. Resolved, he closed his eyes, and his body started to grow tired, and he started to become drowsy.

Okay, very good. Just like this. Nothing more. Then goodnight every-

Just then…

Knock knock knock. There was a knock on his door, immediately reviving the frown that left his forehead. Oh, come on! Lloyd exclaimed internally as he was just about to fall asleep.

I'm going to ignore it.

This time, Lloyd lay on his belly, covering his head with the pillow. But the unwelcome visitor seemed to have no thoughts of leaving him alone.

Knock knock knock knock knock!

Lloyd wanted to yell at the person to leave. But he was already rising up from bed.

Ugh. Let's make this quick.

Lloyd wondered who in the world it could be that the knocking was so fervent. A person from the count? Another emergency? Lloyd sighed.

This is nuts.

He knew from past experience that it was better in these situations to just give the person what they desire. That would make the visitor leave quickly, and he could fall back to sleep in peace.

"Now, what could bring you here to knock on my door in the middle of the night while I was trying to sleep."

Lloyd grumbled as he opened the door, and then he stopped dead. Lloyd was completely frozen when he saw the visitors.

Skeletons. Headless skeletons were in front of the room, and the number seemed to be about 200.

“What now…”

A visit from skeletons at this hour? Lloyd was trying to make sense of things when every single of them suddenly got on their knees. They bowed ceremoniously as their bone joints squeaked. Then the one in the front held out a sketchbook-sized paper, flipping page after page slowly. There were messages they had written in advance.

“You did not throw away our skulls.”

“You are our lifesaver.”

“We want to pay our debts.”

“We will do anything.”

“Can you take us in as we have nowhere else to go?”

“...”

The group of skeletons had come to return a favor during the middle of the night. At their unexpected offer, all sleep left Lloyd, and he became wide awake.

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Chapter 178: When Skeletons Pay Their Debts (2)

“Are you saying that you’re boundlessly grateful to me for not throwing away your skulls?”

Crack!

Slightly past 12 midnight, Lloyd, who was still unable to turn out the candlelight in his room, pressed his eyes hard. He was fatigued. He had been busy all day. After fierce combat with Hell’s Knight, he had to use the Asrahan Core Technique to treat people in the city. And just when he thought he’d be able to finally get some rest, Lloyd received 200 skeletons as unexpected visitors.

“We are more than thankful.”

One skeletal soldier nodded at his question. Then it jotted down a response quickly on the paper. Lloyd wondered if it was the leader of the group. It introduced itself as “Turtle Neck.” Grabbing the piece of soot in its hand, Turtle Neck wrote next.

“We were lost. As if that wasn’t bad enough that we died an unjust death, only our skulls were buried in the cold ground. And our bodies were used as headless zombies.”

“Oh,” reacted Lloyd in realization, “So, the zombies that protected the dark magicians yesterday were you guys?”

“Yes, that is right.”

“And now?”

“Most of the dark magicians are dead. The power of Cannavaro has been shackled. As a result, we were freed from the curse. In the process, all of our rotten flesh has disappeared, leaving us as nothing but bones.”

“Um, then what about the zombies I killed?”

“They are over there.”

Turtle Neck pointed to one side, where two soldiers were raising their bony hands.

-From left, they are Square Jaw and Frozen Shoulder.

“...”

“When you first attacked the warlock yesterday, they were completely knocked out. Their bodies were gone.”

“Oh, yes, that happened,” agreed Lloyd.

“But once the curse was lifted, the bones that turned into powder were restored. But we do not know the detailed reason or explanation behind it.”

“Whatever the case is, it’s all good, isn’t it?”

“Yes, that is right.”

Turtle Neck nodded its skull. It flipped to the next page, as there wasn’t any space left to write, and started to scribble on a new piece of paper. Its black letters filled the white paper.

“Once the curse was gone, we were gathered in one place. We discussed among ourselves what we must do onward. To tell you the truth, it was a short discussion as we all had the same feeling.”

“Feel what?” asked Lloyd.

Turtle Neck tapped its skull with its hand.

“Our heads.”

“Skulls?”

“Yes. We already had the same feeling. That someone had excavated our skulls. Moreover, the person hadn’t thrown them away, and instead, kept

them safe.”

“Wait, are you talking about what I did with the skulls?”

“Yes.”

Turtle Neck nodded once again.

“I have heard everything. How you respectfully bowed at our skull each time you took a jewel. How you wished us peace even though you didn’t know what hardships we went through. How you wished for us to rest in peace.”

“...”

Lloyd shut his mouth. Those words were what he said out loud every time he dug out the skulls. He had thought that was the decent thing to do for the dead as he pitied those that were used by the dark magicians. He simply spoke his heart out loud, promising himself that he’d bury them in good soil.

I didn’t know they were listening.

Lloyd was slightly content but embarrassed at the same time. Just then, a thought interrupted him. One winter, when he was still living in a rental room in South Korea, he was coming back home after receiving his set wage for the day from the construction site. On his way, he spotted an elderly woman setting vegetables on the street. All she was selling were about three or four baskets of plants, but it looked like she wasn’t making any sales. And without any fur hats or gloves, she strove to clean up the piling snow from the vegetables. Her hands were blistered. It was probably because of this sight that prompted Lloyd to walk up to her and ask how much the vegetables were. He then brought out an envelope that contained his pay.

Later that day, I thought I was wild for doing that.

Sure, he did an act of kindness, and it was a good deed. No doubt. But how he regretted it after that night! A loser. A buffoon. An idiot. Lloyd was berated with regret that he was the most foolish person. Why? He had to go for several days without food since he spent all his money. From that day onward, Lloyd refrained from being too kind. It was only natural after learning the price of an impulsive act of kindness. Being kind was good, but it had to be done within his capacity. He had been living his life with such resolve. It had been the same as in his recent days and even right now. And so, it was no different when he excavated the skulls to get his hands on 200 stones. He kept the skulls because it was something that fell within his capacity. He had done it out of respect. It was beyond Lloyd's imagination that he'd be rewarded in this manner.

"Um, in short, are you asking me to take you all?" asked Lloyd.

"Yes, that is right."

The leader of the skeleton soldiers, Turtle Neck, nodded and wrote its response.

"Without you, we would not have found our skulls to this day. They were buried with a magic spell."

"Is that so?" asked Lloyd.

"Yes."

"But if you follow me, you'll be put to strenuous work. Is it okay with you even if you can't rest while you're dead?"

"We have been given life after our deaths anyway. There is no rest for us. Our only destiny is being wiped out by adventurers and armies as we wander in the wilderness. Instead of that life, we choose to live under your official and reliable protection."

"Huh. That makes sense. Right?"

Lloyd grinned as he turned to the side. Javier was sitting on the edge of the bed, his eyes still heavy with sleepiness.

What is going on?

Javier sighed loudly. He was sleeping well as usual after hearing Lloyd's lullaby and enjoying his dream until the bedroom started to grow noisy. Javier started to hear Lloyd's voice, and there were a lot of clacking and cracking sounds. Wondering if it was an enemy, Javier slightly opened his eyes, only to be terrified by what was happening in the room. Anyone would have screamed in a panic if they, too, witnessed their room packed with 200 skeletons right after waking up. Had Lloyd not explained the situation to Javier just in time, he would have charged and smashed every single skeleton he saw in a snap.

Who'd have imagined that I would meet a person who uses skeleton soldiers as construction workers?

That very person was the young master he served. Another sigh. While Javier sighed, Lloyd distributed the employment contract to the skeleton soldiers.

"What is this?"

Turtle Neck cocked its skull.

"An employment contract," replied Lloyd obviously.

The corners of his lips were pulled upward. Why? He had a lot on his mind about the labor supply problem, and he had been wistful for not having undead soldiers even when he held the Zombie Domination skill.

[The number of undead soldiers you can dominate: 200]

[The current number of undead soldiers under your domination: 200]

And now, I've got an infinite amount of workers free of charge!

The rewarding message appeared in front of his eyes, and Lloyd smiled in contentment.

***

The next day, Lloyd went out of his lodging once the sun rose. He was heading to Count Namaran's office, and in his hand was a roll of documents. They were the construction plan and construction blueprint.

Lalala! Lala!

Last night, Lloyd was able to solve the labor supply issue thanks to the contract. As he had been industriously surveying and designing the construction before the wall incident broke out, he managed to outline the construction schedule in advance. Now that everything was set, it was unnecessary to delay the date. All he needed was to hand the construction plan to Count Namaran and ask for the latter's cooperation in providing the materials needed for the actual construction.

Finish the construction. Get the construction money. Go back to my fiefdom. And et voila! A shining life of clover awaits me now that the apartment complex and the sewage system has been completed.

This construction would be the last. With just one more push, he'd be able to receive a maintenance fee from this fiefdom, which would become a good enough pension to last him for the rest of his life.

Lalalala! Yes, yes!

His shoulders quirked in joy on their own, and humming, which was all out of tune and melody, flowed out. He even tap-danced his way up to the count's office. But when he entered, something entirely unexpected met him.

"Will you be my son-in-law?"

"..."

What was going on now? Lloyd stared at Count Naraman as he felt his breathing losing that previous excitement. The count was covered with a thick blanket, and he had a terrible coughing fit.

“Ehem!” *Cough! Achoo!* “Was my request too abrupt?” asked the count.

“Ah, yes. Just a little...”

“To be honest, I did not expect to make such a request, either.”

The count bitterly smiled with a wretched face.

“Lloyd Frontera, I am sure you can look at my face now. How do I look?”

“Um, slightly ill, Your Excellency.”

“Right? And that is the reason.”

The count sighed and continued to speak.

“This incident... It has been terribly difficult for me. My body feels like it belongs to someone else. The doctor tells me that a year of recuperation will help me, but... I am not sure. The evil warlock took away too much of my energy with his game. To be honest, I wish to rest now.”

“Excuse me?” asked Lloyd in surprise.

“Is that so surprising? Haha. I am saying I wish to rest. Retire.”

The count chuckled happily.

“If I were an ordinary old man, I would not have done this. I would have tried to stick to my place. But who am I? I am the ruler of this city. How can I then rule over the city when I cannot even take care of my health? No. No. That is not the case and will only hurt everyone.”

“But Count Namaran-”

“I love this city,” the count interrupted first, “I devoted my whole life to this place, Namaran. And that is why it will only create problems for this old man to reign over things when I should be recuperating. So, I thought that I should find someone stronger, healthier, and smarter. Someone who can help my city. That kind of person should govern the city.”

“Ehem, Your Excellency? I do not think I was being frank with you a while ago, but...”

“Hmm?”

“You look more than fine.”

“...”

“So healthy that you could get to your feet now and run until you reach the opposite side of the wall.”

“Haha, this fellow.”

The count chuckled, and all of a sudden, Lloyd felt alarmed. His attempt to dismiss his words didn’t work. The count appeared adamant as though he had a firm resolve. Soon, Lloyd’s thoughts were actualized when the count called someone into the office.

“You must have been waiting for long. Step out now.”

Right after the count spoke, a door in the office opened from which Lady Namaran came out. Head down, her cheeks glowed in rosiness as she sat beside the count. The count looked at her daughter with a contented gaze, which moved to Lloyd’s way.

“What do you say?” asked Count Namaran. “How about starting a relationship with this child? Moreover, do rule over the city for me.”

“...”

“Do accept the request of this old man.”

“...”

The count’s voice grew more desperate. Lloyd was flustered to the core.

Woah, this is wild.

Lloyd had thought the Namaran’s Wall incident was over. And that was why he only

Goodness, I think I accomplished too much for this place.

Lloyd sweated profusely in his hands because it looked like he had over-accomplished things here. The city redemption and killing Hell’s Knight. Though he had expected that a reward that wasn’t ordinary would await him, it never occurred to him that the count would be willing to present him with his daughter and the whole city. This, in all seriousness, was a massive offer. Just one nod and he’d become the count that rules over Namaran. And if he was bequeathed with the Frontera fiefdom in the future, he’d amass the tremendous power of governing two counties.

But...

For some reason, he didn’t want to. He wasn’t feeling it. Was it because he wasn’t greedy for power? Or because he felt it was way too much? No.

It does not sit well with me.

That was his honest opinion. And he didn’t like the idea of tying the knot with Lady Namaran, whom he had no feelings for. Besides, ruling over two counties would only give him a headache.

Reigning over the Frontera fiefdom is hard enough. It’s complicated and tiring. All I want is to stay in a quiet fiefdom and spend the rest of my life enjoying the goodness of life. But everyone seems to be hell-bent on giving me more responsibilities.

If he held the power to select his life genre, he’d choose the calm, peaceful life story. Or he’d choose to become a character who enjoys life as a landlord. Ambition for power, risky adventures, overcoming disasters... All

of those options weren't his cup of tea. They wore him out, and it was more so because he had already worked his ass off in South Korea. All he really wanted was a modest, peaceful life. And so...

I have to turn down this offer.

Resolved, Lloyd racked his brain for a reasonable way to reject the count's offer, one that would forever stop him from making this kind of offer ever again. What would it be? What excuse would prevent him from doing so? Lloyd's gaze suddenly moved to Lady Namaran, and it naturally hit him. He recalled the tragic and dramatic ending of her story arc. Her noble sacrifice for the city.

"Your Excellency," said Lloyd, "I well understand what you mean, and your cause. But please forgive me. I cannot accept your offer to be your son-in-law and to rule over this city."

"What...?"

The count's eyes shook.

"Turning down such an amazing offer?" the count continued in dismay, "Do you not know what this offer means? What could be the reason for your rejection?"

It looked like the count was flustered considerably. Well, it made sense. After all, he was proposing to hand over his daughter and the whole city. Any normal person would have begged on their knees to receive this offer. But not Lloyd. He instead fixed his eyes on the count with aplomb, and in a serious face and voice, he spoke.

"As there is a ruler who is more befitting than I am to rule this city. And she is here."

Lloyd pointed at Lady Namaran.

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Chapter 179: A Reliable Supporter (1)

Lloyd's hand moved and pointed at the seat beside the count across from Lloyd. He was pointing at his daughter, Lady Namaran, and that made count's white beard twitch.

"My daughter? She is an excellent ruler?" inquired the count.

"Yes, Your Excellency."

"What do you mean by that?"

Followed by his beard, his eyebrows twitched next. Lloyd's words were a mystery. Old and in severe need of rest, he needed a successor to rule the city after him. And unfortunately, he didn't have a son but an only daughter. As such, he contemplated the matter for several days. Who was a suitable candidate? Or should he overtax himself and endure a little longer? That was when it occurred to him that there was Lloyd. Practically and nominally, he was a good candidate.

He's young and competent. He's clever, industrious and has accomplished a great thing for the city. Not only that, he is greatly favored by Her Majesty. There is no one better than him who can reign the city.

That was the conclusion the count drew at last. And so, he had made an offer to Lloyd. Marry my daughter. Be my successor and rule this city. Assured that Lloyd would accept the offer, the count waited in anticipation. From the count's standpoint, no, according to common sense, his acceptance was only obvious since it was a tremendous opportunity to become a count at a young age and rule over the great city. But what?

He refuses and tells me that my daughter is a more fitting ruler for the city?

Such a possibility never crossed his mind. His daughter was just his daughter and nothing more. He simply wished that she would marry a good man and help advance the family line. Though he cherished and loved her, he never imagined handing the countship to his daughter, who had been

sheltered and had never seen the harshness of life. Her being a ruler never crossed his mind.

“Are you mocking this old man?”

Count Namaran scowled, wrinkling his eyes. Though old and sick, he nonetheless gave off the force befitting a man who has ruled over a city his whole life. But Lloyd remained calm and unperturbed despite the other’s glare and tone of voice. He neither grinned nor shrugged. Instead, he looked at the count with a more serious look.

“Your Excellency, I am being sincere,” said Lloyd.

“Sincere?” asked the count.

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

Lloyd slightly nodded, alternately looking at the count and Lady Namaran.

“What will I ever attain by mocking you?” asked Lloyd, emphasizing every word. “I have no intentions of that. So, please consider my words, Your Excellency.”

“Then where are you getting at? How is my daughter a suitable ruler of this city?”

“I also meant every word when I said it,” said Lloyd.

“Sincere?”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“And where is your basis?” demanded the count.

“I saw it myself. I saw how her unreserved hesitation and sacrifice the day the cursed wall was erected,” said Lloyd solemnly.

“What could you mean...?”

“I saw how exhausted she was after guiding the old servants and maids to the shade.”

A soft smile escaped him. Lady Namaran. His smile deepened as he thought about her more. It was because of the deeds she manifested in the novel and this life.

How could she be so relaxed?

In the novel and his current life, in both worlds, she wore a pendant, which was her father’s childhood gift. But it wasn’t an ordinary pendant. It was rare and held the invaluable power of partially protecting the effect of various spells and curses. Thanks to it, she managed to stay awake longer than other people, even when the wall was put up. She had enough strength to crawl with some struggle.

And that was how she thwarted Cannavaro. By crawling. She used all of her body to thwart and disturb that warlock who was in the ritual to summon Hell’s Knight. That was how she died, and those few seconds she bought allowed Javier to stop the summoning ritual.

That was how she met her end in the novel. And what about here? Though she didn’t die, she did good deeds relying on the power of her pendant as she strained to take care of the elderly servants and maids. She guided them towards some shade and massaged their arms and legs. Then, even when she was on the brink of fainting, she continued to nurse and tend to them until, at last, she passed out.

“I accidentally spotted her while I moved around treating people. And I heard it too. The servants and maids were all praising her,” Lloyd said, “the sight they saw as they lost consciousness. How the lady strove to take care of their menial existence. How they will never forget that scene for the rest of their lives.”

Lloyd sent a content gaze at her. But her face was bright red. Could it be because her good deeds were revealed? This made his eyes glint with more contentment.

“That is the kind of person your daughter is, Your Excellency,” Lloyd continued, “She is always ready to sacrifice herself and give her life to this city and its people anytime.”

“But this girl has never reigned-”

“Certainly,” Lloyd cut in modestly, “she lacks experience.”

Before the count could rebut, Lloyd began to speak, slowly persuading him.

“Of course, she’ll probably make many mistakes at first. But she will learn from them. But will it not be the case for me as well? I am also certain the same applies to you, that is, when you were young, Your Excellency.”

“Ehem...! Ehem! Why do you have to cite me as your example?” huffed the count.

“I simply wanted to say that we all start somewhere,” defended Lloyd, “especially in a position that involves ruling a city and shouldering countless lives. And that is why...”

Lloyd pointed at Lady Namaran again.

“If everyone will be inadequate in the beginning, why not leave it on someone who is ready to completely devote herself to the city?”

“What about you?” asked the count.

“I am not cut out for it, Your Excellency. I can’t.”

“Why do you say so?”

“Because I am greedy,” replied Lloyd with certainty in his voice. “I might increase the tax by tenfold right away. Why shouldn’t I? This isn’t my hometown. And I’m not particularly attached to it. Well, speaking straightforwardly, I couldn’t care less whether the people here starve or not,” drawled Lloyd.

“I can see that you are saying that on purpose,” pointed Count Namaran.

“Yes. I am trying to emphasize that at least your daughter will never do the things I just said.”

“...”

“What’s more, she is a local here. This is her home. She will be more knowledgeable than a stranger like me.”

“...”

“How does that sound, Your Excellency?”

Lloyd grinned after finishing speaking. Count Namaran shot a meaningful gaze at him. “My good fellow, why are you doing this?”

“My lord?” asked Lloyd in mild surprise.

“I offered a position,” the count went on, “one which anybody would be envious of. I even offered my daughter’s hand with it, making it all the more legitimate. How can you remain so nonchalant as you refuse this offer?”

“I have told you, Your Excellency, I am greedy.”

“What?” Count Namaran frowned.

“In all honesty,” Lloyd said casually, “money isn’t the only thing I’m greedy for. I am avaricious when it comes to leisure as well. That is why I secretly pray every night that my Count Frontera will live long, even after he reaches 100 years old.”

“Your reason... seems far from filial piety.”

“That is right,” Lloyd answered. “It’s more convenient for me if he lives a long, healthy life.”

There wasn’t a single lie in his words. He liked Count Frontera as a respectable leader. And so, he dearly wished that the count would live a long life. After all, a count’s son had fewer responsibilities compared to the

count. The less work there was for him, the more things he had to enjoy. Just like that, he would lead a comfortable life of relaxation.

“That’s who I am,” continued Lloyd, “After going through a lot physically and mentally, I am now drained. I want to rest. I don’t want to be burdened by too many responsibilities. I simply want to live a quiet life, enjoying what I already have,” replied Lloyd, his voice dripping with exhaustion.

“Do you not have any grand ambitions or dreams as a man?” inquired the count.

“Ambitions and dreams do not put food on the table, Your Excellency.”

That certainly was the case. A modest life. An ordinary life. A life of having just enough. Lloyd simply wanted to live without a care in the world and pass away when his time came. His ultimate dream and wish were to live as a lazy landlord.

“I see... Since you are adamant... I cannot force my will on you,” said the count in resignation.

“Thank you, Your Excellency, for acknowledging my will.”

“But I won’t immediately agree with your drastic plan to designate my daughter as the count. However, I will give my full consideration for it.”

“That is very relieving to hear. I was getting worried that I crossed the line,” answered Lloyd.

“Haha, what a brazen fellow you are,” chuckled the count.

“While you are complimenting me, Your Excellency, please say that I am tactful.”

“Tsk. It would have been wonderful if you reigned the city,” the count said wistfully.

“Lady Namaran will do a much better job than I ever could, Your Excellency.”

“Now, where is the man that worried whether he had crossed the line?”

“Was there such a man?” joked Lloyd.

“Ahaha. How strange. I do not hate you even when you act like this.”

“There is nothing special about me. It is all because of your generosity, my father-in-law, oops. I meant to say, my count.”

“Hahaha! Look at you!”

The count finally burst into laughter, and he gazed at Lloyd more meaningfully than before.

“I see... I will seriously think over your advice.”

“Thank you, Your Excellency.”

“No,” the count said as he waved his hands, “the gratitude is mine. Had it not for you and Sir Asrahan, I, my daughter, and this city would have perished. While we are on this topic, I have something to say. Thank you very much. I will make sure to give a detailed report to Her Majesty about your accomplishments.”

“Um... About that...” mumbled Lloyd.

“Why,” the count asked, “do you not want me to?”

“The thing is, having too many accomplishments can also be troublesome.”

A bitter smile escaped Lloyd. The count’s gaze grew with more contentment.

“Hahaha. Is that so? I see. Then I will hire a skilled writer to narrate your dramatic feat to Her Highness in great detail.”

“Please, spare me, Your Excellency.”

“I will not,” refused the count. “This is my way of getting revenge for how you coldly turned down this old man’s favor.”

“...”

“Anyway, let us put this subject behind us. What do you have over there?”

Still holding the grudge, the count spoke as he pointed at Lloyd’s side. Lloyd’s face lit up at his question.

“Oh,” said Lloyd, “it is the blueprint and plan for the slope stabilization project.”

Welcoming the change of subject, Lloyd immediately brought out the document and opened it up.

“First, I analyzed the characteristics and current state of the cliff slope that supports the city. I found that the slope is considerably damaged... Blah blah blah... The pressure on the side is expected to be high... Blah blah blah... Therefore, the piles in the ground must be installed in a file, and the anchor bolts will increase the friction resistance... Blah blah blah...”

Lloyd started to pinpoint and explain the blueprint so eloquently that the count was left speechless. A proud smile bloomed on Lloyd’s face as he spoke. He had succeeded. He peacefully turned down the unexpected proposal and passed off the responsibility of ruling the city. Therefore, his plan was completed. Once this construction ended and he went back to the Frontera fiefdom with money, he’d be able to achieve his modest dream of living high off the hog.

Lloyd continued to explain the project with an expectant heart, and he finally got the promise of assistance necessary for the project. Count Namaran glanced at Lloyd with the most satisfying gaze as he listened to the latter’s explanation. His gaze was likened to the warm look of a grandfather looking at his grandson with a 4.0 GPA. But such a gaze had nothing to do with Lloyd’s amazing explanation or his stellar accomplishment. None of it.

He’s really a man I’d like to keep by my side.

Lloyd Frontera. Young and competent. But there was something else the count paid more attention to. Despite Lloyd’s competence, he was humble and never crossed any lines. He had the wit to evaluate himself objectively and never went beyond his limits. Count Namaran judged that such a character wasn’t something most ordinary young men could manifest.

By and large, a competent man usually holds confidence that equals his skills. And so, he starts overstepping boundaries while becoming arrogant and conceited. Losing the capacity to objectively evaluate himself, he falls into delusion. That is when he makes a mistake, hurting himself and everyone around him. But Lloyd? He’s different. He already knows how to restrain himself despite his skills.

The power to restrain himself despite holding such tremendous talent. That quality was greater and rarer than his talent itself. That was at least the way the count saw him.

I tried to win over him too easily.

Count Namaran realized that Lloyd wasn’t the type of person he and his city could easily get a hold of. He reprimanded himself as he looked at Lloyd and secretly made a resolution.

A sharp nail may try to hide under a cloth, but its end will inevitably pierce out. Talent is the same. No matter how much he tries to leave in peace, someone will eventually desire his talent. And eventually, he will find himself in turmoil at least once in his lifetime.

Count Namaran resolved that should such a time come for Lloyd, he would step up and protect this young man, the savior who saved his daughter and the city. When a chaotic storm rushed to hit Lloyd Frontera, he would strive to protect this man’s peace even if it took everything he had. He would return the favor he received at least once in his lifetime. Resolving such, Count Namaran eyed Lloyd with a gentle look. For Lloyd, that marked the birth of a reliable supporter who was set to become a great help in his future.

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Chapter 180: A Reliable Supporter (2)

Now, the construction took off in full swing.

We can now get started since the anchor bolts I ordered came out perfectly.

It probably was the day after Lloyd declined the count's offer. The blacksmiths in the city visited him early in the morning, lugging about a 23-foot metal anchor bolt in length.

It was high quality for a prototype.

They surely were the blacksmiths highly recommended by Count Namaran. The anchor's size and functionality mostly satisfied Lloyd. In particular, the wedge part of the bolt they'd produced after referring to the wedge lock bolt was done so wonderfully that Lloyd nearly gasped in amazement. It met almost all of his demands.

The furrow of the wedge end is perfectly burrowed.

Thanks to that, the construction gained more momentum. Lloyd ordered a considerable amount of anchors to be produced based on the prototype. And with that, he knuckled down to constructing.

"All right, you might feel awkward because this is your first construction with me. So, I have a question I want to ask first. Is this anyone's first construction?" asked Lloyd.

"..."

"Since you guys can't speak, raise your hands. Raise your hands if this is your first time in a construction like this."

Clack! All 200 skeletons raised their hands. Lloyd's eyebrows quirked slightly.

"Seriously? All of you are rookies?"

Clack!

“How so?”

This actually was the very part Lloyd had been worried about. Seeing Lloyd’s flustered expression on his face, Turtle Neck, the leader of the Skeleton Corps, stepped forward and held a piece of paper and soot.

“Do not worry so much. They simply cannot remember their life before this.”

“What?” asked Lloyd. “They can’t remember?”

“Yes. It goes the same for me too. Nothing comes to my mind. What I used to do, and what kind of person I was.”

“Aha. Is that the reason why you guys called yourselves Turtle Neck, Frozen Shoulder, and whatnot?”

“Yes. We completely forgot our old names.”

“Hmm. You all are like a blank piece of paper.”

“But there have got to be some of us who worked on a construction site before. Who knows, our bodies might remember something.”

“Well, I hope so. Ehem! Anyway.”

Lloyd’s gaze moved to the Corps.

“This may be the first construction some of you take part in while others may remember their past experiences. Regardless, it is everyone’s first time doing construction with me.”

Clack! 200 skeletons raised their hands, happily clicking their lower jaws. Lloyd smiled.

“Oh, you don’t have to raise your hands anymore. Anyway, I want you to mark this in your bones. Safety first. The most crucial thing in construction

is safety. So, don’t scurry or scramble. It’s bad for your joints. Even if you have to work slowly, be safe and precise. Or else, you’ll be the one who suffers the consequences of getting injured. Got it?”

Screech! Creak!

“Did you actually mark my words in your bones...”

The Skeleton Corps marked the words “Safety First” in their bones before holding their shovel. Javier, listening to Lloyd’s speech beside him, lifted his sword as he took on the most crucial role in the slope stabilization project that was about to start.

“You know what to do, right? Bore the holes,” instructed Lloyd to Javier.

Lloyd then held up a large brush, painting several points in the slope with red paint. Though his action seemed random, all the marks he made had been carefully calculated and designed. Javier knew this because he was an old hand in constructions like these that were led by Lloyd.

“Please tell me the direction, angle, depth, and diameter of the hole,” requested Javier.

“Vertical. Thirty-nine feet in depth. Three feet in diameter,” said Lloyd.

“Yes, Young Master.”

Javier held up his sword high right after the numbers for boring the holes were laid out, and he stared at the painted floor. His grip tightened, and his eyes held a glint of faint rage. But was it because he was regarded as a piece of construction equipment? No. It was the opposite.

I am ashamed of myself.

Javier was mad at himself. He had no right to complain about being forced into construction work. After all, this was the only thing that he was good at. When it came to fighting a powerful enemy, he struggled and couldn’t handle it by himself. Even though that very enemy was no other than Hell’s Knight, it didn’t change the fact that he wasn’t enough and that he required

the help of Lloyd, the very person he was supposed to protect. That indisputable fact washed over him as a wave of shame and guilt. His duty, responsibility, and mission. He was overwhelmed with self-hatred for failing to uphold even one of them.

Yes, I have been too insolent.

It must have been after he rose to become the sword master. He was unwittingly getting too content with himself. In the corner of his heart, he was telling himself that this was enough. Holding this much power was enough. Could it be that he was settling for the present too soon? Could it be that he was thwarting improvement by doing so?

I cannot deny that was the case... The moment I deny how I was, I won't be able to even dream of improving in the future.

He had pathetically struggled in his fight against Hell's Knight. He'd have been defeated without Lloyd's help. Javier repented deeply in his heart as he replayed those moments in his head. And so, he resolved that he would improve further. He would never again put his master and the fiefdom in danger. Therefore, he couldn't even overlook the time he spent at construction sites like this. He would treat these moments as opportunities for training. With such resolve, he opened his eyes, which flashed with determination. Next, his sword radiated light.

Flash! His sword moved like the wind, stabbing down like a flash of light and bursting like thunder.

Kaboom! Kaboom! Each time Javier moved and stuck his sword in the earth, the mana blast burst, but its explosion was somewhat different from the past ones. Whereas the previous mana blast caused a rough explosion in the ground, this one never went an iota of an inch beyond the range Lloyd instructed. It was because Javier had controlled the range of the explosion by nano inches with all of his might. That was a tremendously difficult job, and it was exhausting. But Javier kept using it on and on nonetheless.

Speed of power. Range control. More meticulously. More powerfully in the targeted areas!

Each sword strike would add to his training. Even when all he did was swing his sword at a construction site, it would be the case. From now on, even breathing and walking would be regarded as training for him, a step toward self-improvement. Just like that, Javier's sword continued to dance in a fierce and meticulous manner as he continued thinking. Dozens of sleek vertical holes that were 39 feet in depth and 3 feet in diameter were bored into several areas of the cliff slope. Next, it was time for the Skeleton Corps to work.

"Okay!" shouted Lloyd. "Let's move it!"

Crack! At his shouting, the Skeleton Corps rose, carrying a 42-foot long and 3-foot thick log on their shoulders.

"Focus now! And don't forget! You have to move at my shout to avoid getting caught in your feet! One fall, and it's going to ruin the balance of the people around you, and everyone could fall under the logs! Mark my words!"

Clack! The skeleton engineers nodded, moving ahead in order at the shouting and moving the large and heavy logs. These were the round piles that would be inserted in the vertical holes that Javier had excavated in advance and stabilize the foundation.

They're like the toothpicks used to hold burgers together. Stick them in, and the patties, bread, and lettuce won't fall to the side. The same goes for the land. The sturdy foundation rock and the weak surface have to be held together by sticking these logs into the earth.

But unlike with a burger, there would be more than one stabilizer used. The piles would be inserted in a series for a stronger effect. Lloyd was greatly satisfied by the trees that were used for the piles, and the credit was due to the climate of the region.

It's always dry and cold out here throughout the year because of the high altitude. That makes the wood as robust and sturdy as metal. Moreover, they grow plentiful around here.

The thick stump was about 3.2 feet in diameter, and it was more than enough to work as a pile. Lloyd knew it was the case because he had tested it with the simulation skill a host of times.

“All righty, up next, Ggoming!”

“Ggoming!”

Around the time the Skeleton Corps brought the piles in front of the vertical holes, Lloyd yelled, and Ggoming, which was on standby in the air, replied, fluttering his wings to get down. After biting a rope that was tied to one end of the pile, he soared high, and the piles stood up straight.

“Skeletons! Fix the pile!”

Crack! They approached the now hanging pole in the air and adjusted it to fit into the vertical hole. After checking it was good, Lloyd ordered aloud.

“Ggoming! Lower it!” he shouted.

“Ggomiming!”

Ggoming fluttered his wings and slowly came down, and the piles started to get inserted into the holes. A few minutes later, they were all fully in.

Good. Just perfect.

Lloyd clenched his fists as he observed how perfectly the piles fitted in. The pile was produced to be 3 feet in diameter and 42 feet in length to perfectly fill the holes without leaving any space. In other words, the construction had gone perfectly, from the excavation of the vertical holes to the insertion of the piles into the empty spaces in the ground.

“Good! Let’s continue on like this!”

“Ggoming!”

Crack! Lloyd shouted, Ggoming answered, and the Skeleton Corp clapped, the construction moving forward without a break. 15 days passed, and

dozens of piles were inserted, each spaced out from each other by two feet. Wooden planks were then laid across the top parts of the piles to support the force of each other, and the next job was the anchors. First, Lloyd instructed the surface the anchor bolts would be installed in to be smoothed out, and once Javier bored holes there, the workers pushed the anchor bolts into them.

Creak! Tight! They inserted the anchor bolts in the holes excavated 45 degrees in angle to the end and twisted the bar in the middle part of the anchor bolt, which moved to twist the bolt head connected to the bar. The anchor head twisted following the furrow in the ground and entered the body of the anchor bolts. The deeper the head entered, the end of the anchor bolts grew wider in diameter, completely filling up the space inside and tightly fastening. Afterward, Lloyd poured the grout solution into the hole. The solution was a hardener made by mixing the lime with the first-grade glue, which he produced by melting the slime, and it pulled the rope attached to the anchor bolt. Lloyd then looped the other end of the rope to the flat plate installed on the ground. This plate was made of granite and cross-shaped, and six feet by length and width.

The anchor bolt is in the ground. The plate is installed on the surface. In between was a rope that tightly pulled down the plate with its force, which worked to press the slope. To analogize, the piles they had constructed were like toothpicks in hamburgers. And these anchor bolts were like a needle with a thread that penetrated the hamburger. The thread was connected to a plastic plate on the bun. In short, the anchor bolt was a needle. The rope was a thread. The plate was plastic. When the thread was tightened, the plastic pressed the burger, holding down each ingredient. To actualize this design in real life, everyone labored to bore and insert the piles and anchors.

Javier sweated profusely, and the skeletons worked their fingers to the bones. Ggoming fluttered his wings, and Lloyd yelled. This was a daily occurrence. One day passed, and two days passed. Ten... A month, and two months later, the flowers began to bloom in the spring, and the maples in the highlands turned red. Finally, on the first snow day of the season, the tediously long construction was finally completed. The result was successful. The cliff slope that was crumbling away every day saw a

chance. It no longer crumbled down. Count Namaran exclaimed when he saw it with his own eyes.

“Here is the payment I promised,” Count Namaran said a few days later when Lloyd and Javier were getting ready to leave.

“Is this... a carriage?” asked Lloyd, dazed.

“Yes, it is.”

“Pray, Your Excellency, this is not all your payment, is it?”

“Hahaha, of course not. Look inside the carriage,” said the count as he smiled gently.

A sense of expectation suddenly washed over Lloyd.

Is this...

Lloyd began to sense that a great prize was waiting for him. His heart pounding and thumping fast, Lloyd opened the carriage door, and his eyes widened.

“My token of appreciation.”

“...”

Crates. Crates were everywhere, and inside them were gold coins. Am I dreaming?! Lloyd wondered.

“Is this... all mine?” asked Lloyd in a daze.

“Can you not believe it? Hahaha! I decided to be generous. To be honest, I thought of being more generous given how you saved my daughter and city, but I did not like how you turned down this old man’s previous offer.”

“Haha,” said Lloyd, “You didn’t have to, Your Excellency.”

Lloyd grumbled, but he was already grinning ear to ear.

Hurray!

Lloyd discretely clenched his fists. He was looking at five crates packed with gold and silver coins. This was enough to cover all the expenses for the fiefdom and refugees without royal assistance.

Nice. Really nice.

I knew it, Lloyd said to himself, nothing beats money. Money was the best thing in the world. With this, he could spend the rest of his life lazing around and enjoying every good thing this world offered. Confident, Lloyd prepared to depart for home alongside the carriage laden with gold coins and with the Skeleton Corp. Count and Lady Namaran escorted them on their way off. And just like that, Lloyd left Namaran. The journey back home was long, and on the 12th day since they left the city, a few hours before their arrival in the morning, Lloyd gently called Javier, who was cleaning the bonfire at the camp.

“Hey, Javier.”

“Yes, Master Lloyd. Is there anything you need?”

“Javier, my Javier. You can’t play dumb like this.” urged Lloyd.

“I am playing dumb...? I’m not sure what you mean.”

“The bet. Lady Ella. You are to return to the fiefdom in that costume, remember?”

“...”

“You couldn’t have forgotten about it, right?”

“...”

But he did. Javier had completely forgotten about it. His heart suddenly dropped, but Lloyd’s face brightened with a mischievous and evil smile. And then he saw Lloyd’s hands carrying the dress and wig that belonged to Lady Ella.

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Chapter 181: Father’s Waiting (1)

“Bibeong!”

Like always, Biebong’s vigorous shout resounded across Frontera county, the eco-friendly alarm welcoming the arrival of morning. Count Frontera’s heart thumped faster than usual as he met the morning. The day he had been waiting for was finally here.

Today is the day.

The count lifted the warm teacup a maid brought for him and looked out the window. It was softly snowing outside. His bedroom window offered a panoramic view of the cozy garden to the hill leading up to the manor. Since it was the season when branches went bare, the view was clearer in his eyes. The count was glad it was so because it meant a higher chance of spotting his son returning home.

It is likely he will be back by today.

Just then, Count Frontera recalled the homing pigeon that had arrived at the manor a few days ago. It contained the letter formed by Count Namaran, and it shared that Lloyd and Javier left Namaran city and were expected to arrive at Frontera fiefdom sometime soon. Count Namaran also expressed his deep gratitude to Count Frontera.

I never expected my son to go through such an event there.

Count Frontera’s eyes grew serious as he recalled the content of the letter. His son had left for Namaran City, saying that he would be back in no time after finishing the construction project. So, it was beyond Count Frontera’s imagination for Lloyd to go through such a terrible event there, that is, eliminating a group of dark magicians and fighting against Hell’s Knight.

Lloyd clutched the enemy’s leg, an enemy that even Javier couldn’t handle so easily... Whew.

What if things went wrong during the fight? The mere thought of it made his heart sink. Sure, Lloyd had merited another accomplishment now, but it didn’t matter to Count Frontera. Accomplishments or bragging rights were not what he needed. Lloyd was his son, and living a good and healthy life was all the count wanted from him. That was enough.

I should scold him when he comes back.

Count Frontera decided to scold Lloyd to stop getting involved in such affairs from now on and run away when things get dangerous. With that resolve in mind, Count Frontera stayed around the window and skipped breakfast, feeling restless and excited at the same time. He drank another cup of tea instead, but it didn’t quench his thirst. Another cup. Another, and another. The maid entered and left each time, brewing a new pot and taking the empty cups. The morning passed, and the afternoon arrived soon until the short sun of early winter moved southward. Even then, he continued hovering near the window.

Could it be that he’s not coming today? Perhaps he will arrive tomorrow? Or did something happen on his way here? And right around the time Count Frontera started growing anxious, he stopped dead in his tracks and bolted out of the room, taking two flights of stairs to descend down. Passing the main chamber and shoving the door open, he went out of the manor and ignored the maid’s hurried suggestion for a coat. He ran across the garden and looked down at the hill that leads to the manor.

“Oh.”

A carriage was coming up against the snow that had considerably grown thicker, leaving a long track behind its way. It was slowly driving up the hill until it stopped at the main gate of the manor. Just then, Count Frontera let out a squeaky noise.

“Eh?”

His gaze moved to the box seat, and the horseman, who was sitting there, greeted him.

Clack! The horseman happily waved its bony hands and smiled as its lower jaw clacked. Bony hands and clicking jaws. In other words, this horseman was a skeleton soldier.

“Eeeek?”

My son was supposed to be here. Lloyd was supposed to be here, not a skeletal soldier sitting in the box seat of a carriage. Count Frontera was about to sink to the ground in shock when the door opened just in time to save him. If it didn’t, he would have dirtied his pants in the muddy snow.

Click!

“Hmm? When did you come out here?”

It was Lloyd who stuck out his face through the door that opened. He smiled pleasingly at the frightened count.

“U-um, you see,” the count said as he struggled to collect his thoughts. “I came out just now.”

“Did I surprise you? You’re not even wearing a coat in this cold weather.”

“Yes, you see...”

Lloyd was already down from the carriage and near the count. He removed the coat and placed it on the count’s shoulders. The warmth calmed his troubled heart.

“I will be honest with you,” the count said, “I ran out to welcome you, and I nearly fainted in shock. What are those skeletons over there?”

The count pointed at the skeleton on the box seat, but it wasn’t alone. Two files of skeleton soldiers marched up the hill behind the carriage like rows of sausage links. Lloyd shrugged.

“Um, Count Namaran mentioned that he would explain the events that had taken place through the letter,” Lloyd mused. “But I suppose he skipped the part about the Skeleton Corps?”

“S-skeleton Corps?” repeated the count.

“Yes.”

“What is that?”

“My new workers.”

“Those skeletons are your workers?”

“Yes.”

“...”

“They’re friendlier than they appear,” assured Lloyd. “They may be eerie at first, but once you spend time with them, you will get used to their company. What’s more, they are hardworking and never slack off. Oh, allow me to introduce you, the one sitting on the box seat. That’s Turtle Neck, the leader of the Skeleton Corps.”

Clack! Turtle Neck waved its hands happily at the count. Lloyd then pointed to the rest of the skeletons.

“The two standing in the very front of each line are Square Jaw and Frozen Shoulder. As for the others... I have yet to memorize them because their names confuse me,” said Lloyd.

“...”

“Anyway, do not be afraid. They don’t bite.”

“...”

Count Frontera thought to himself that they looked like they would bury people alive, not bite, at one false move. He strove hard to push away the eerie feeling. Just then, Lloyd’s face grew serious, and he looked back. The count wondered if there was more to see than the current group of skeletons.

Smirking at the inside of the carriage, Lloyd said, “Hey, don’t you think it’s time for you to come out?”

But no one answered. Lloyd’s smile grew more mischievous.

“Hello?” asked Lloyd, “Are you possibly embarrassed?”

The count wondered who else might be there. That was when he realized that he hadn’t seen Javier. It was a cloudy and snowy day, so the inside of the carriage was hardly visible. Unable to make out who was in there, the count narrowed his eyes to slits. Just then, a cynical response came from the inside.

“Embarrassed? That’s a misunderstanding.”

“Then?” asked Lloyd.

“I was rearranging my skirt.”

“To look pretty?”

“Certainly. I’m trying to mind my manners toward my lord, whom I am meeting after a long while. I could never show such an untidy appearance in front of him.”

With that, Javier stepped out of the carriage. Count Frontera’s mouth hung wide open in sheer shock. But he wasn’t alone. The servants and maids that followed him and the countess that rejoiced in the return of her son from afar suddenly felt as though the world around them became blindingly bright at the sight of Javier.

Oh, everyone exclaimed. The world was such a beautiful place. They wondered if it was the weather that was bright. That was how gorgeous the sight of Javier getting off the carriage and straightening the hem of his modest dress was. The way he got down on his knee and paid his respect to the count. His appearance, the wig, the apron, and the old shoes were all modest, but they hardly mattered. Javier was ravishingly gorgeous. A simple bow made him glow to the point that nearby onlookers were

abruptly overcome with the desire to be crushed between the small wrinkles on his forehead. In short, everyone who stood outside the manor was lost for words at the sudden appearance of Lady Ella.

“Knight Asrahan, I am honored to be in your presence.”

“Oh... mhm.” *Cough! Cough!* Flustered, Count Frontera broke out into a coughing fit. Lady Ella, no, Javier rose and stood up after paying his respects to the count. He then strode across everyone, still speechless and flustered to the core. Before anybody could stop him or ask any questions, Javier entered the main gate as though he was fleeing the scene. He crossed the garden and hurriedly entered his chamber in an annex building of the manor. A second after he set foot there, he threw the wig and dress into a garbage bin to make sure that they would be unwearable in the future.

“Whew.”

Javier sighed, wondering what led him to do such a thing. Just then, he recalled what happened earlier in the morning. It was the last morning of their journey to his fiefdom from Namaran. Just like always, he tidied up the campsite, and that was when Lloyd approached and asked if he had forgotten anything with a suggestive gaze. Subsequently, he swayed that despicable wig and dress in front of him. Javier couldn’t fight. He had made a bet. A promise had to be kept.

There won’t be any reason for me to wear those clothes now.

Never again. Javier would make sure that was the case. He resolved so as he stared at the wig and dress crumpled inside the bin. Then he sulked inside his room all day, never setting even a toe outside.

***

The following morning rolled around.

“Hey, Lady Ella.”

“...”

“Lady Ella?”

“...”

“Sir Asrahan?”

“Yes, what do you need?”

Javier’s reply was icy. Lloyd grinned at his attitude.

“Did what happened yesterday upset you a lot?” asked Lloyd.

“Not at all. I was not upset.”

“But your door was locked. I came over at night to sing a lullaby for you since it had been a while.”

“I was sleeping,” said Javier curtly.

“Really?” asked Lloyd, raising his eyebrow.

“Yes.”

“But I heard you sigh.”

“I must have done so while I was asleep.”

“No, it couldn’t be,” Lloyd rebutted. “I heard a shaky sigh coming out of your nose like you were trying to hold back your anger.”

“I must have been having a bad dream,” retorted Javier.

“Like what?”

“Like meeting Master Lloyd in my dream. Or talking to Master Lloyd in my dream. Or eating with Master Lloyd. Or being near Master Lloyd. Or spotting Master Lloyd from afar. Or hearing news about Master Lloyd. Or seeing a cow dung that resembles Master Lloyd. Those kinds of dreams.”

“…”

“Should I go on?” asked Javier.

“Yes, it’s very interesting. It sounds like just hearing me breathe is enough to offend you,” said Lloyd.

“I see you’re aware of it.”

“Yes, that is why it is so fun to tease you.”

“Is that so?” asked Javier. “Master Lloyd, you must be thrilled.”

“Why would I be?”

“For you will be stripping the bachelor title you have been holding for the past 27 years soon.”

“Hm? What do you mean?”

Lloyd cocked his head. He was still single and didn’t even have a girl he was interested in, let alone a girlfriend. So, what was the knight talking about? Javier gave a chilling response.

“Soon, it will be another year, and you will be in your 28th year of being single.”

Lloyd was too shocked to speak.

“Congratulations in advance,” said Javier.

“Ah, yes. Thank you. I’m crying tears of joy,” said Lloyd dryly.

“Not at all.”

“…”

Lloyd felt like he messed with the bull and got the horns. Or as though he threw a tiny marble and then was socked in the gut with a shot put ball.

Forcing a bitter smile on his face, Lloyd spoke.

“So, do you feel better?”

“Yes. Thanks to you, a little bit.”

“Yeah? Then let’s go.”

“Where to, Master Lloyd?”

“To the construction site.”

Lloyd spoke as he straightened his collar to block the cold wind. He had fully recovered from his travel after taking a day off yesterday. It was time to do the work he had been pushing off.

“The apartment complex and major sewage system. I received the report from Sir Bayern last night, but I should check with my own eyes.”

While Lloyd and Javier were out in Namaran, Sir Bayern accomplished numerous things. He reported to Lloyd that he had done an excellent job in finishing the apartment complex and the sewage construction.

“So, let’s go see for ourselves.”

Starting that day, Lloyd inspected the apartment complex and main sewage system for the next five days, making sure that everything was built according to the original design and no defects were found. Lloyd inspected the whole place with a fine-tooth comb, even using the surveying skill. The result was highly satisfactory.

Good. I think I can give it 90 points out of 100.

The apartment complex pleased him very much. Those who live upstairs might experience some inconveniences taking the stairs, but it was good enough shelter from the rain and cold. Just like that, people started to move into the apartment complex. The elderly and those with disabilities took the lower floors, while the relatively young and healthy individuals took the upper floors. The units weren’t particularly flashy or large. The structure

simply allowed them to sleep inside. But that alone was enough to make them rejoice as they had lost their homes after being stricken by the Monster Domino phenomenon. The event led them to reside in a refugee camp with harsh living conditions for over a year. But now, they finally owned a house that allowed them to stay guarded against the rain and wind.

Well, taking the stairs will surely be a bother, but for now, this should be enough. And once things get a little better for them, they can build their own houses and move out of here.

And when the complex units became empty, Lloyd could turn this whole building into a dorm for the engineering corps and guards.

But that will happen later. As of now, I've overcome one major obstacle.

On the final day of the move-in, Lloyd threw his body on the bed, completely drained out and exhausted. Though he was fatigued, he was content. He must have received thousands of thank-yous in the past few days from refugees who were joyful to get a home for their new life. It was his first time receiving so much praise and gratitude.

Well, it kind of makes sense.

If someone suddenly came up to him and handed him a key to a free studio apartment out of goodwill when he was living in a room rental in Korea, he would have been overwhelmed with gratitude too, just like them.

I've done a good deed. And it's going to benefit me in the future.

Now that they had all moved into the apartment complex, they were no longer refugees. They were now proud residents of Frontera county.

And all of them will pay taxes.

A lifetime pension. The thought of it made him smile ear-to-ear.

Ahh. Great! The refugee problem's been solved. I won't have to worry about the fiefdom's finances for the time being, thanks to the money and jewels

from Namaran. Well, well, looks like all that’s left is to sit back and enjoy life.

There weren’t any large construction projects or turmoil in his future. He would just enjoy a quiet and luxurious life. Resolving that, Lloyd was able to fall asleep soundly. And the following day, Lloyd welcomed the envoys of Queen Magentano, which were dispatched to depart for the sultan's kingdom.

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Chapter 182: Father’s Waiting (2)

Fwick! The letter opened, and a serious gaze looked over the paper.

“Hmm.”

A wrinkle appeared on Queen Magentano’s forehead.

“Hell’s Knight, huh.”

She searched her memory. She read a mention of it in an old book, about how it was a knight that led a corps in Hell. But it had never ascended to earth since ancient times. The book warned that its arrival on earth would bring an apocalypse for every living being.

Should I be relieved that Hell’s Knight was summoned in such an imperfect form?

The kingdom could have been reduced to dust, but that didn’t happen. All the credit was due to the brave knights and people of Namaran. They thwarted the dark magicians’ schemes and struggled until they succeeded in suppressing Hell’s Knight. The report, written by Count Namaran, informed her.

But I question the veracity of this report.

Under the flickering candlelight, the queen’s eyes held a faint smile as they read the report. Something didn’t sit right.

Certainly, I could believe that Namaran’s knights defeated and arrested a group of dark magicians, but Hell’s Knight? Regardless of its defects, they really managed to defeat it?

She could not believe it.

The report added afterward is more suspicious.

Her gaze moved downward, which detailed how Hell's Knight was subdued.

Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera family, was residing in Namaran just in time, and his singing threw Hell's Knight into great confusion. Thanks to it, Sir Javier Asrahan and the other knights worked to defeat the formidable enemy. But hmm... What kind of song must one sing to perturb the knight of hell?

She couldn't imagine it. But she could faintly catch what was going on inside the report.

Count Namaran downplayed the report at the request of the eldest son of the Frontera family.

The queen could sense it right on. Certainly, she wasn't at the scene to witness the event. But the hints and clues from the report allowed her to postulate so.

To begin with, Hell's Knight is not an enemy the knights of Namaran can fight against. That is, even if they risked their lives. Yet the report says the knights worked together with Sir Asrahan. No. In reality, Lloyd Frontera and Javier Asrahan were probably the only ones that fought against Hell's Knight.

The queen harked back to the past, particularly the night someone tried to assassinate her and the capacities Lloyd and Javier showed on that night. Javier suppressed Sir Kyle, the sword master. And Lloyd manifested a variety of talents and skills even though he wasn't a sword master. Based on that night, the duo would have put up a good fight against Hell's Knight, as the latter was imperfect.

But it is a wonder as to why Count Namaran understated their role in his report. Hmm, is he trying to help Lloyd lead a quiet life?

Just when her thought reached that point, Queen Magentano smirked. She was well aware of Lloyd's modest tendencies. How he wasn't ambitious

and longed to live an ordinary life. The reports she had gathered in various ways allowed her to detailedly understand his character.

That must be why he asked the count. He must have requested him to understate his role.! But too bad. Lloyd Frontera. Cannavaro, the very man transferred here last night, will end up confessing everything. Furthermore, I plan on making good use of you for the time being.

A competent individual was to be used. Ignoring one's talent was wasteful, and it bordered on being sinful. The more tired capable individuals became, the more prosperous the kingdom and people's lives became. This was especially true at this critical juncture when the kingdom was experiencing a diplomatic row with a powerful neighboring nation.

"That is the reason why I included Lloyd Frontera in the delegation. Am I wrong?" asked Queen Magentano, her question echoing heavily in the study.

"You are certainly correct, Your Majesty," answered the foreign affairs secretary standing politely beside her.

"Correct? But did you not tilt your head in confusion regarding my plan up until I dispatched the envoys? Did you change your mind?"

"Certainly not, Your Majesty."

"Then what do you mean?" asked the queen.

"Your humble servant simply wanted to make inquiries and express his opinions until a decision was made, Your Highness."

"Do you mean that you will not make an independent judgment on my decisions?"

"Yes, Your Majesty. However..." said the secretary, stopping midway.

"However?"

The secretary hesitated to speak.

“Do speak,” the queen urged, “I will not reprimand you for your opinions.”

“Thank you, Your Majesty. To reveal my thoughts, I am simply curious about what we benefit by including Lloyd Frontera as an envoy,” said the secretary, his words careful.

Deepening her smile, the queen said, “Hmm, I see what you are saying. Are you wondering what contribution Lloyd Frontera will make to the delegation when he is not an expert in diplomacy?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“To be honest, I have no high hopes for him, either.”

“Your Majesty?”

The secretary lifted his head, his eyes lifting in confusion. Queen Magentano smiled softly.

“Lloyd Frontera will only act as the face of the envoys. He is a symbolic figure that represents the countless victims of the Monster Domino phenomenon.”

“Is that all, Your Majesty?”

“Yes, that is it. However, I cannot say that I have absolutely no expectations of him.”

“Then...”

“I have never seen a man stingier than him.”

“Your Majesty?”

The secretary tilted his head in confusion, and the queen scoffed.

“From the moment I was born,” the queen went on, “I grew up in the political arena of the kingdom. I had to overcome countless competitions and feuds to rise to the throne. And I have met many people along the way.

The wicked, the fierce, the fool, the cunning, and the clever. But Lloyd Frontera was different."

"Do you mean that you saw a side of him that stands out from the others?"

"I did. It was my first time encountering such a hard-working yet cheap person who's also incredibly stubborn and petty all at once."

"..."

"The reason why I hold high hopes for him is probably because of his character. I think he may come back to us with a surprising achievement."

"..."

Queen Magentano's calm voice rang aloud the study, and because of that heavy atmosphere, the secretary couldn't dare answer anymore. He simply hung his head down, thinking to himself.

Is she cursing the man or complimenting him...?

He couldn't ascertain it. So, he only wished that the delegation dispatched to the sultan's kingdom would strike a successful negotiation and not end in a war.

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"Excuse me? So, um, are you telling me that I have to join the envoys for us to avoid a war with the sultan's kingdom?"

"I am certain that you know this as well. This is not coming from me. It is an order from Her Majesty."

Flip! Tick! The scroll of royal order rolled up. Count Ventura, the head of the envoys, spoke after he finished reading the queen's order.

"Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera family, I have no doubt that you know this as well. A royal order from the queen must be abided by at all costs."

“Ah, yes, I am aware of that, but-”

“The delegation departs tomorrow morning. Make sure you are ready before then.”

Whoosh. Count Ventura turned around. The empty spot he left behind was replaced with a cold gust of wind that hit Lloyd’s chest.

Ha...

The sigh just came out naturally. What in the world happened? Lloyd wondered to himself. He was happy up until last night. The refugee issue was all taken care of as the apartment complex and the main sewage system had been completed. He had earned a great sum in Namaran, and so he had nothing to worry about for the time being. There were no signs of any more trouble. And so, Lloyd thought he was set for a happy, lazy, and prosperous life.

My queen! Why are you doing this to me?!

Lloyd blamed the queen, who was in the palace far, far away from him, and recalled the event of this morning at the same time. It must have been right after breakfast. Lloyd felt slightly more sleep deprived than usual, so he decided to sleep more and threw himself on the bed, happy and content. That was when he heard a fuss on the first floor, and he heard the servants and maids moving around.

Curious as to what was happening downstairs, Lloyd went out to the corridor, and he met the count and countess hurrying down the stairs. Stopping short, the count turned around and told Lloyd that the royal messenger of the queen was here. He should dress up and get down. Lloyd wondered what it could be about and suddenly got an ominous feeling. After changing into formal clothes, he got down and kneeled. He carefully listened to the royal envoy reading the order. The order was simple yet destructive. Lloyd was to join the diplomatic delegation, which was heading to the sultan’s kingdom. It ordered that Lloyd must assist the team that would be engaging in diplomatic negotiation with the sultan.

Me? The delegation? Help them? How?

Lloyd couldn't put his finger on it. But he had a vague idea of a role he could potentially take on.

What, am I the face?

Lloyd racked his brain, and it was clear as day as to why the queen would send the delegation to the sultan in the east.

Monster domino.

The queen was holding them to be accountable. She was trying to obtain compensation and a diplomatic agreement to prevent such an event from happening again. That had to be the reason why the queen put him on the team. The Frontera fiefdom was one of the places that were harmed by the phenomenon. It was the only fiefdom that survived and became the hub for reconstruction.

She's making me the representative of the victims. Yeah. That's it. I'm the witness in charge of describing the damage that was done to this region.

That was it. That was the purpose of sending Lloyd.

Haa… Did I whine too much the last time?

Lloyd looked back to the time he received funds from the queen. He had whined and thrown an ugly tantrum in the letter he sent, and that must have left a powerful impression on her.

That's why she's sending me. To whine and cry before the sultan like that time, so I *can spice up the negotiation. Goodness.*

Lloyd felt bitter. The royal order had already been announced, so there was no way of refuting or refusing it. In other words, Lloyd was forced to join the delegation first thing tomorrow and go to the sultan's kingdom.

I never thought I'd have to visit the sultan kingdom.

But it wasn’t a light, carefree journey. Suppose the delegation failed to strike a negotiation, and the sultan brazenly refused to be held accountable. In that case, the diplomatic row would worsen for the two kingdoms. That could lead to war, which would be a disaster for the Frontera fiefdom.

We’ll be dragged into the war between the two powers.

In the case his kingdom lays a siege first, the Frontera fiefdom would become a bridgehead for invasion. On the other hand, in the case the sultan's kingdom attacks first, the fiefdom would turn into a defensive frontline. In short, his fiefdom would become a battlefield, and Lloyd detested the thought of it in either scenario.

“Are you sure you will be all right?”

“Oh, yes.”

Count Frontera placed his hand on Lloyd’s shoulder, and Lloyd smiled at him as he turned. Truly, Lloyd didn’t welcome this situation wherein he had to abruptly leave the fiefdom again. He was even more bitter as his plans of spending his life in a peaceful retirement was delayed. But what else could he do? And since he was ordered to go anyway, he might as well finish up quickly and return. Thinking so, Lloyd got ready for departure. But there really wasn’t much to prepare.

I’m just a member of the delegation, so yeah.

The food and lodging would be all provided for. Starting a fire or getting a tent ready would all be taken care of by the people in the delegation, so Lloyd simply needed to pack a few of his clothes. And something else to kill his boredom during the journey.

“And that is me?”

“Duh. Of course.”

“Do I exist to kill your boredom, Master Lloyd?” asked Javier.

“Yes, Of course.”

Lloyd nodded his head at Javier’s question.

“Did you think you would be staying in this fiefdom while I am being dragged to that far, distant kingdom?” asked Lloyd with a nonchalant look on his face.

“Yes.”

“Wow. You didn’t even hesitate to give your answer.”

“I am merely a man who follows the lord’s command.”

“And the count hasn’t ordered you to protect me. Is that it?”

“That is right.”

“Tsk. I’m pretty sure he has just forgotten to.”

“What do you mean?” asked Javier.

“He didn’t bother to give a separate order because it is too obvious that you will go where I go. Don’t you think so?” asked Lloyd.

“No.”

“That is what you wish to believe. Anyway, let’s do this. I will go and ask him to let me take you.”

“...”

“Hoho, you’re thankful and moved to tears. Right? Think about it. What if you stay behind here all alone? How will you sleep?”

“Sleep? That is something-”

“Something very precious,” interrupted Lloyd. “Sleep greatly affects the body and mind. And you’re going to give that up?”

“I think that is better than being haunted by you, Master Lloyd.”

“And what if something terrible happens to me there? Are you fine with that?”

“Yes, of course.”

“...”

“Why are you staring at me like that, Master Lloyd?” asked Javier.

“You know, I just thought that I have to take you with me. Really, I can’t go alone. That’ll be unfair.”

“...”

“So, hold on for a second here. I’ll go to the count and request that you come with me. Then I’ll sing you a lullaby.”

Lloyd left Javier’s room and skipped toward the count’s study. The inside of the room was brightly lit. However, there was a faint shadow on the count’s face as he welcomed Lloyd. Was it because he had to send his son again after going through all the trouble in Namaran? Or because he was worried about the things Lloyd would go through there? They were right, but there was an even bigger reason.

“I am glad that you are not asleep. I have a favor to ask you, my lord,” said Lloyd.

The count looked at his son, Lloyd, who entered his study with a grin. He wondered the last time Lloyd had called him “father.” It had been too distant in the past that he couldn’t remember.

“I see... What do you need?”

The count decided not to push Lloyd just yet. Let’s wait until he opens up. Resolving such, the count beamed.

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Chapter 183: Father’s Waiting (3)

It was snowing softly at first. But as the night wore on, it thickened, carpeting the ground under the midnight moonlight. The white field of snow received the first mark of footsteps. Count Frontera turned to the side as the crunching noise of the footsteps whispered in his ears.

“I hope you are not cold,” said Count Frontera.

“I am not. Not very much,” Lloyd replied, and the count grinned as he glanced sideways at his son, who was walking beside him. Seeing Lloyd by his side pleased him. His heart was bursting with contentment.

“I am afraid that I am pestering you,” said the count.

“Not at all. I am fine,” said Lloyd.

“Are you starting to feel tired?” asked the count again.

“Not yet.”

“Should we,” suggested the count, “walk a little longer then?”

“I was just about to suggest that we do.”

“Haha. My boy.”

He laughed again. Count Frontera felt happy every time he looked at Lloyd. He even hated that the foggy breath coming from his laughter momentarily hid Lloyd’s face. The count was on cloud nine as he strolled through the night.

I will have to say goodbye to him for a while again.

Lloyd had just returned from Namaran after a long period of time, but he was set to leave again after a few days. He was to join the envoys and travel to the sultan’s kingdom. When will he return then? Next spring when the

flowers bloom? It was because of this sorrowful thought that the count abruptly suggested a night stroll when Lloyd visited his study.

“Tell me if you are feeling cold or tired,” said the count, “a long journey awaits you tomorrow morning.”

“Don’t worry. I’m not very tired.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes.”

Silence again. The two walked side by side, sometimes one taking the lead. They held out their hands when their path turned slippery. Just like that, they strolled around the hills, stone walls, and woods. The count suddenly was hit with memories of the past, and as he glanced at the snow piling on his son’s shoulder, he started to take a trip down memory lane.

“You know,” the count started, “when I was young...”

Lloyd quietly listened as he kept pace with the count.

“I despised this fiefdom,” the count said as he collected his breath. “I was frustrated, bored, and sick of it.”

Count Frontera smiled faintly. He really was tired of it at the time. When he was 17 years old, this fiefdom felt like a giant fence that locked him up.

“I thought it was too rural. I was not happy that I had to spend the rest of my life as a small noble in the middle of nowhere.”

“Was it because you were ambitious?” asked Lloyd.

“Ambition... I can’t say. I was young, I suppose.” The count chuckled, but no sound came out. “I wanted to do something. Something grand and shiny, not this boring life in the province. Would it be funny if I tell you I wanted to be in the big league? Anyway, I wanted to make a name for myself. So, I decided to do it. I left home.”

“Wait, did you run away from home?” Lloyd glanced at the count, his one eyebrow quirking up to reflect his surprise.

“Hmm...”

The count gave him a bitter smile.

“Run away?” continued the count. “It’s a bit of an embarrassing way to put it, but I cannot find a retort back. Yes, you are right. I ran away from home. I left this fiefdom in the middle of the night riding the very horse your grandfather cherished very much, without any notice. It’s fair to say I ran away.”

“Yes, you certainly did.”

“Could it be the reason why? Was I getting punished for it? My life afterward was filled with hardship.”

“By hardships, you mean...” mumbled Lloyd.

“I volunteered for the mercenary in my desire to succeed on my own and prove that I was capable. Then I regretted it.” The count smiled bitterly.

“Imagine it,” he went on, “I was just a seventeen-year-old kid who had no experience with swords other than swinging them around my guards as practice. Who would hire me? That was why the commander barely put me to proper work. Three months of chores, and that was it.”

“You must have been sorely disappointed,” said Lloyd.

“Yes, at first. I wondered if this was all I was capable of. But I endured. I endured believing that my time would come. And my, it really did.”

“How?”

“I met a girl there.”

“Oh,” said Lloyd, his eyes shining for a second.

The count smiled.

“I think it was snowing like this. The commander called me, and there I saw a girl about my age captured there. A big crime she committed, he said. That she will be sold for slavery. He told me to watch her so she would not run away.”

“Then?”

“I asked the girl secretly,” the count went on, “whether it was true. She told me that it was a lie. The truth is that the commander and his team had ransacked her village. That was when I realized.”

“That the mercenary group looted and robbed villages when they were out of work,” Lloyd joined.

“Yes. That was why he put me to chores and nothing else,” agreed Count Frontera.

“What did you do after you learn that?” asked Lloyd, piqued.

“I ran away. With the girl.”

“All safe and well?”

“No.”

The count grinned.

“We fled at midnight, and we were being chased even before the sun rose. So, we galloped, everything around us growing hazy. Of course, with the girl behind my back.”

The count’s gaze moved to the falling snow, and he spoke, his eyes traveling back in time.

“We ran for our lives. But how tenacious they were. We could not get rid of them no matter how far we ran. And on the sixth day, we were surrounded.”

“But given that you are all alive now, I suppose it didn’t end badly?” asked Lloyd.

“It did not. Your grandfather showed up.” The count paused before continuing to talk. “Unbeknownst to me, we were near the western border of my fiefdom when we were captured. I was too busy that I could see it. Thankfully, my father found me. He had been patrolling the fiefdom every day at all hours since I left home.”

“In case you came back home?” asked Lloyd.

“It must have been so. Anyway, he found us just in time and drove away our pursuers with his guards.”

“That concluded your life as a runaway?”

“Indeed. It also concluded the biggest adventure of my life.”

“Then what happened to the girl you came with?” asked Lloyd.

“She is your mother.”

“Woah.”

Lloyd let out an astonished sound, and now he understood how the count and countess maintained such a happy marriage. It never occurred to him that they had such a backstory.

“From then on, I realized dearly at last how much my father cherished me. The same way I cherish you, son,” the count said.

“...”

“Are you feeling shy?”

“Uh, um, it’s not that, but...”

“Then?”

“May I be frank?” asked Lloyd, almost mumbling.

“Yes.”

“I got goosebumps for a second there,” Lloyd said.

“Hmm? Hahaha!” The count broke into laughter.

“Please forgive me,” Lloyd replied.

“No, no,” the count said. “I can understand why.”

The count chuckled as he tapped Lloyd’s shoulder. But he didn’t really care whether Lloyd got goosebumps. If he could, he wanted to tell Lloyd more. I cherish you truly and sincerely. The grand masterpiece, the best chapter of my life is you, Lloyd. Please stay safe on this trip too. That would be more than enough for your old man. Count Frontera yearned to tell these things to Lloyd through the night even after midnight. But he suppressed his desire because he didn’t want to make Lloyd uncomfortable. And what’s more, he wanted to give his son time.

Until the day comes when you call me father again, Lloyd.

Some time ago, his son had completely changed from being a hooligan into an industrious, faithful man. But something else also changed. Lloyd stopped calling them “Father” or “Mother” altogether. Count Frontera was pleased and joyful about the change, but at the same time, wistful and sad, However, he resolved that there wasn’t any need to show it. Lloyd had to open his heart on his own. And as a parent, all he could do was wait until his son fully opened up to them. With such thoughts in mind, Count Frontera ambled on, Lloyd walking on his side.

Whew...

Lloyd sighed internally. He, too, had discerned what was going on. He could not help but notice that the count and countess were bothered by his attitude and how he wasn’t calling them “Father” or “Mother.” He also

knew that this saddened them, and they felt sorry about it. However, it wasn’t easy for him to act according to their wishes.

I’m sorry. But I don’t want to act with affectation.

The count and countess were good people. And Lloyd knew very well that they thought dearly of him. That was precisely why he didn’t want to be pretentious around them. He didn’t want to call them father and mother just to please them, as it would only mortify the good couple and be using their innocent hearts. Lloyd never ever wanted to do that. And that was why...

I’m sorry. Just give me some more time.

Until his heart is ready. Until he could nonchalantly brush off the pang of regret and guilt that attacked him for replacing their real son, Lloyd. Until he could come clean to them and bare his heart to them. When the very day came when everyone could accept each other as family, that would be the only time Suho would be qualified to call them his parents.

“I will try.”

In the lack of confidence to say it out loud, Lloyd just mumbled under his breath. And as the snow continued to fall, it was impossible for Lloyd to see how the count was reacting beside him. He simply couldn’t work up the courage to turn and look. But he could feel it somehow. Like a soft feather, like a night wearing on so comfortably, the moon reflected with her light a breath of air coming out of the count. And Lloyd was sure. It was definitely a trace of a soundless, quiet smile.

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The morning came, and Lloyd joined the envoys as expected. Of course, Javier was with them.

“Mwahaha.”

“Why are you... laughing so mischievously?” asked Javier.

“Does it irk you?”

“Yes. Very much.”

Javier frowned slightly at Lloyd’s question. He started to load his belongings on the back of the horse just a tad more roughly.

“Could it be because you are happy to take me with you?”

“Yeah,” answered Lloyd joyfully.

“Why does that make you happy?”

“Because I won’t have to suffer alone.”

“So sharing suffering makes you happy?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“I’m happy that you’re suffering with me.”

“...”

“It’s unfair that I’m the only one who has to go work there. So, I have to drag at least one person along on the trip. I’ll make him work together beside me. That way I’ll know that I’m not the only one plodding away, and that there’s at least one person going through the same thing as me. I won’t feel alone in my misery. Don’t you think that would give me comfort?”

“This devil...”

“Hm?” asked Lloyd, suddenly shooting a surprised glance at Javier. “What did you say?”

“I said you are a devil.”

“Why, yes, thank you.”

“...”

“Better than being a soft touch.”

Lloyd smirked as he stared at Javier, who started to laugh at his brazenness. And Javier secretly regretted that he didn’t call Lloyd a mole cricket. That could have been a more effective insult. Javier resolved that he would use it the next time. Meanwhile, the envoys were done packing and ready to go. The departure was nothing grand.

“I sincerely express my gratitude to Count Frontera for your unreserved hospitality during our stay here. So long then.”

With the comment of gratitude from Count Ventura, the envoys set off on their journey. Lloyd and Javier bid farewell to the count and countess and left. They headed to the east, climbed the eastern range, and then passed the wasteland, nearing the border of the sultan’s kingdom that sat in the east.

They revealed to the corps commander guarding the border that they were on a diplomatic visit. From then on, the journey became safer and more efficient. The envoys were the official diplomatic delegation dispatched by Queen Magentano, and thus, acted as her representative in sharing and defending her will. They received treatment and respect befitting of their status throughout the sultan’s kingdom territory. And at last, the envoys arrived at “Ahinsya,” the capital city. It had been 24 days since Lloyd left his fiefdom.

“Wow.”

Lloyd found himself exclaiming out loud after passing Ahinsya’s front gate.

What an exotic sight.

Far east from his fiefdom, and far southward from there. The climate was dry due to the location even though it was the middle of winter.

If I was a film director for Arabian Nights, then this place would be perfect for the shoot.

Arabian Nights. The city’s ambiance reminded him of the story. There were round roofs erected everywhere, and the walls were made of dried mud. The atmosphere was completely foreign and exotic to Lloyd.

“Please follow me.”

An official who seemed to be sent by the sultan came to escort the envoys and entered the kingdom. Lloyd was totally engrossed in seeing the structure of the palace.

Wow. This is pretty educational.

Lloyd was surrounded by foreign architecture. Certainly, he didn’t major in architecture, which was poles apart from civil engineering. But the two studies could be traced back to the same foundation. Accordingly, Lloyd’s eyes glimmered as he viewed the various styles and designs. And after a long escort, the reception room door opened, and inside was...

“Are you certain that you are not mistaken?”

Count Ventura’s voice was filled with dismay, which brought Lloyd to look into the hall. There was nothing there. It was extremely simple and austere to a fault. The narrow space seemed unfitting for the palace, and even the table and chairs felt out of place. Rather than simple, it looked cheap. No, it was too shoddy to be called cheap. In other words...

“There must have been a mistake. We are envoys who traveled a long way here to uphold the orders of Her Highness Alicia Termina Magentano. And yet, you present us with a reception room that does not suit our status. Is this where the sultan will meet us?”

Count Ventura’s gaze darted to the palace official as he asked, and the same look of confusion appeared on every member of the delegation. Meanwhile, Lloyd put on a faint smile.

Haha. Will you look at them?

Lloyd merely chuckled, almost certain that there was no mistake here. It was impossible for the sultan to be this clumsy. Therefore, it was an evident show of maltreatment. Lloyd plastered a wry smile as he read the room before the others did. Just then, the door inside the hall opened.

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Chapter 184: Hurray for the Sultan (1)

This feels quite familiar.

The corners of Lloyd's lips rose, but it was more of a smirk, not a smile. His gaze then traveled to the inner door of the room, which was opening up. Another man, who appeared to be a palace official, walked inside and paid mechanical respect to Lloyd and the others. Then, with a stoic, expressionless face, the man spoke.

"Thank you for traveling all the way here. Please have a seat over here," said the man as he pointed at the table in the reception room.

The table was plain and lacked any decoration, and the same went for the chairs around it. They were chairs that were commonly used in most houses. In other words, this room wasn't set up to entertain diplomatic envoys sent by a foreign monarch. Count Ventura, the one leading the delegation, expressed his dismay.

"Ha... There seems to be a mistake here," announced Count Ventura.

"By mistake, what do you mean?" the official asked.

"I think you brought us to the wrong room."

"I am still clueless as to what you are saying." The official cocked his head to the side with a straight face. This caused Count Ventura to complain further. His voice reflected greater dismay.

"It seems there was a miscommunication on your end causing this mishap to happen. We are special envoys sent by no other than the great queen, Her Highness Queen Alicia Termina Magentano. In other words, we traveled far and wide to speak on her behalf to the sultan. Despite that, we are brought to this small and shoddy reception room. Moreover, to be met by a lowly official instead of the sultan? I don't understand why," said the count at length.

“Why don’t you understand?” the official nonchalantly asked.

“The treatment we received is unbecoming of our status. Do me a favor and go back to your supervisor and ask whether you brought us to the correct place.”

“I am sorry,” said the official, “but I escorted you to the correct place.”

“What is? This place?” the count said as he looked all around. “This small and shoddy reception room where you led us?”

“That is right.”

“How...?” The count’s face shook.

Still wearing a robotic and expressionless face, the official said, “I led you to the right location. Tell me, aren’t you all the envoys from Queen Magentano?”

“We are. I made that clear a while ago.”

“Yes. Then you are in the right place.”

The low-level official only repeated those words like a parrot, and Count Ventura’s eyebrows twitched.

“Is the sultan intent on insulting the queen?” huffed the count.

“That is not something I know. I am simply fulfilling the orders given to me,” the official defended.

“Then bring me your supervisor!” Count Ventura bawled at last.

But the palatial official didn’t even bat an eye. He nodded in a stiff manner, and that was it.

“Understood. Then please wait here for a moment.”

Once the official left, Count Ventura started to bite his underlip in anger.

“What in the world is happening...”

Is he trying to control his rage? Or could it be that he just can’t understand the current situation? Probably both.

Lloyd smiled bitterly as he read the room.

It took everyone a while to get a grasp of the situation. Well, it’s not surprising. These people here have probably never been treated like this before.

Lloyd’s eyes moved to look at Count Ventura and then studied the rest of the members. Everyone belonged to noble families that held considerable influence in the capital.

No wonder they never received this kind of treatment before. That’s why they’re having trouble grasping the situation. They aren’t used to this. It’s foreign to them.

A wry smile continued to escape Lloyd, and his mind flew back to his time in Korea, particularly when he lived in a room rental.

People looked down on me all the time.

He barely had anything. There was nothing for him to boast. After losing his parents, he struggled each day to put food on the table. So, he never dared to treat himself, and that nuked his confidence. He couldn’t hide his cowering attitude that naturally came from his expressions and movements. From that moment on, people started to look down on him quite subtly. The manager of the building joked every time he saw Lloyd, saying, “Make sure you have your rent this month, you hear?” And there was more.

And to all the envoys, have you ever got on a crowded bus only to realize that you didn’t have enough money for the fare? With that thought, have you ever started frantically rummaging through your pocket in panic and spilled a handful of coins to the ground? And after you picked the coins up while apologizing to the other passengers, have you ever realized that you were

still a quarter short? Then were you ever forced to get out of the bus again with all the people glowering at you for causing a delay?

The experience still made his stomach churn even now. However, it was because of his disparaging life in South Korea that Lloyd was able to grasp the situation the moment he was led to this shabby reception room. He knew how the sultan planned on treating the envoys. What the sultan was doing wasn't a mystery to him at all. He caught on immediately. He was accustomed to being looked down upon.

They're probably going to be more shameless from now on.

Lloyd took a seat at the table in one corner, deciding to see whether his prediction was right. And while he remained in his seat, observing the situation from one step away, a man who seemed to be a high-ranking official entered the room.

"I heard you wanted to see me," said the supervisor.

"Yes. I did."

Count Ventura, who was walking to and fro with anxious steps, reacted right away, and struggling to put on a calm face, he spoke to the official.

"I just can't properly get my words through to a low-level subordinate," explained the count.

"Hmm, what is the issue here?"

"This place," Count Ventura said. "I assume there has been a slight but grave mistake."

"Oh, I already heard that you expressed dissatisfaction regarding the reception room. But, unfortunately, this reception room has rightfully been assigned to you." The official smiled respectfully.

"What?" Dismay. Count Ventura's eyes were filled with dismay. "Then... What about the sultan? Does he not plan on entertaining us?"

“Regretfully, that will be the case for now.”

“Regretfully? For now?” the count repeated.

“Yes.”

“What do you mean by that?”

“The great and omnipotent sultan is overseeing a plethora of construction projects at the moment. Therefore, he cannot entertain you all as there’s too much work for him to catch up on.”

“But we are the representatives of Queen-”

“I am aware,” interrupted the official. “You are the diplomatic delegation sent by the queen. However, nothing can be done.”

“This is... outrageous!”

As the count shouted aloud, the veins in his neck bulged out of his skin.

“I am trying to be patient, but this has gone too far! What kind of a kingdom treats royal envoys like this?! This is not appropriate diplomatically, and it is out of line!”

“But,” said the official coolly, “there really is nothing we can do.”

“There is nothing you can do? Do you expect me to just accept that?!”

“If you disagree, then you can always go back.”

“What...?” Count Ventura stopped short, wondering if he heard him right.

The corners of the official’s lips rose in a strange manner, and he added, “I have expressed our stance well enough. Let me reiterate to you, the great and omnipotent sultan is currently unavailable to entertain you.”

“So what, we wait?”

“Now you understand our side. Yes. Wait, and the issue will be solved naturally,” stated the official.

“How long should we wait?”

“At least six months.”

“What-”

“As I said, there is nothing we can do. The great and omnipotent sultan is just that busy.”

“Are you mocking us?” challenged the count.

“Not at all.”

“Then what are you doing?!”

“Asking for your understanding.”

“How could you ask for our understanding for such a ridiculous request-”

“If you dislike it, then you can always go back.”

Thump. The official smiled faintly, bringing out a circular gold plate. He then set it on the table.

“The choice is yours to make. Go back now, or stay here and wait. We do not intend to force a decision on you.”

“What is that...?”

Count Ventura pointed at the gold plate with his jaw. The official grinned.

“It is a gift personally bestowed by the great and omnipotent sultan.”

“A gift?”

“Yes. It is a gift you can receive should you choose to wait.”

“Do explain...”

“The golden plate is called ‘Padashar.’ Its use is simple. Have this, and you will not need any money during your stay here in Ahinsya.”

“How so?”

“This Padashar represents the grace of the great and omnipotent sultan. It marks his promise to provide everything you will need during your stay here.”

Seluk, which was the name of the official, continued to explain.

“Carry this wherever you go in the capital, and you will not need to pay for your food. The same goes for when you buy clothes, hire camels and workers, and pay for your lodging.”

“Are you simply treating us like beggars now?” asked the count defiantly.

“You misunderstand me. How would I dare to?”

But the corners of the official’s lips were already up, and it made the count’s eyes tremble.

“Then I will give you some time to think over it. Please excuse me.”

While the rage and dismay continued to swell over the delegation, the high-ranking official bowed and left the room. Lloyd’s smirk on his face deepened.

It’s like I expected. I’m right.

The sultan kingdom. It was explicitly looking down on the delegation. Go back home if you hate waiting. Be in our favor if you wait. In other words, they demanded the envoys toss their pride to the ground, or the negotiation was off. The sultan kingdom was indirectly suggesting nuking the negotiation just like this. They wouldn’t be treated this way otherwise.

Are they planning to deny that they're responsible for the Monster Domino incident?

That seemed to be the case which was slightly problematic for Lloyd.

There'll be a war if the agreement fails.

Lloyd had a bad feeling about this. War had to be avoided. War breaking out was no good for anyone, particularly for the Frontera fiefdom, which would receive tremendous damage.

What's the delegation planning on doing?

Here came the crucial part. How the envoys responded to the preposterous attitude the officials manifested would determine the results of their discussion. But surprisingly, Count Ventura and the delegation remained still, doing nothing, their shoulders only drooping in discouragement.

"Haah. What do we do...?"

"Indeed," one of the envoys agreed. "I never imagined that they would receive us in this fashion. How does this make sense?" Count Ventura expressed his confusion.

"I agree with you. This is not right. We must summon someone in charge again and express our complaint."

"Indeed. We must do it. But what if it doesn't work?" rebutted Count Ventura.

"How about openly condemning the sultan?" one of the envoys suggested.

"Hmm, but we are in the enemy's territory," reminded Count Ventura.

"Then how about we send a letter to the kingdom?" the same official suggested.

"What kind of letter?"

“We will write a letter detailing their lack of respect toward us and ask for a larger delegation.”

“Do you mean to say,” mused the count, “we ask the palace for diplomatic support and pressure?”

“Yes, Your Excellency. Realistically, there seems to be nothing much we can do here.”

“Hmm...” Count Ventura stroked his beard, thinking hard about the subject. “I am clueless as to what we must do. But giving up on the negotiation and going back will only disappoint Her Highness. The war will become inevitable should that happen... But you, what are you doing?”

The count’s brow twitched, and his question was directed to the person in the corner of the room sitting at the table. Lloyd was there, and he grinned at the count.

“Oh, I was taking a gander at this one.”

Lloyd was holding a gold plate in his hand. It was the Padashar the official left on the table. When the count saw it in Lloyd’s hand, his brows trembled hard once more.

“Pray, do you desire that object?” asked the count.

“It seems interesting. That’s all,” Lloyd replied.

“Drop it. That object was given to mortify us. I expect you to keep your curiosity to yourself. And besides...” The count’s gaze grew stern as he looked at Lloyd. “You saw how they treated us, didn’t you?”

“Yes.”

“Then do you have any suggestions for us?”

“Um, nothing much.”

Lloyd shrugged after he spoke. A look of discontentment appeared on the count's face and vanished after a second.

How materialistic he is.

Actually, Count Ventura never liked Lloyd in the first place. Was it because a man from the sticks received favors from the queen? Or because he considered Lloyd to be an upstart? No. Count Ventura admitted that Lloyd was a capable and reputable man. But he hated the strain of materialistic character Lloyd manifested from time to time. For instance, it was right now. Lloyd was stroking the gold plate the sultan handed out to mock them. Count Ventura stared at Lloyd.

"May I advise you on one thing?"

"Yes, of course," answered Lloyd.

"The gold plate you are holding. Stay far away from it. Do not exchange your reason for greed. And do not sell your pride for negligible gains. Most of all, do not spoil our visit here with your foolish behavior."

"Yes. I understand," answered Lloyd.

"Do you mean it?"

"Of course," confirmed Lloyd. "Do not worry. I will not ruin this for everyone."

"Thank you. Thank you for seeing where I am coming from."

"No problem."

Was the count relieved at last? Count Ventura nodded in satisfaction. Lloyd responded by flashing a smile at the count to make sure he appeared trustworthy.

And that very night, Lloyd took the gold plate of the sultan and threw the biggest, wildest party of his life.

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Chapter 185: Hurray for the Sultan (2)

A credit card. A common object anybody with income carried around in South Korea. Depending on an individual's personal finance credit, they could purchase goods and services on their card and pay it back later. Made of plastic, it was 3.375 inches wide and 2.125 inches high. But Lloyd never owned a credit card before. South Korea and its banks never permitted him to own one. The reason was simple.

Why else? I was pretty much a beggar.

He was young when his parents were alive. Getting an allowance was more than enough for him. But once he grew up, around the time he was old enough to use a credit card, his family went under. And then his parents passed away so soon that he was forced to live in a room rental. He could only make a living by working his butt off on construction sites to cover his expenses. So, making a credit card was impossible. Not a single bank in Korea issued him one.

That was the reason. I could only use a debit card and a transportation card.

Those wretched days came to his mind. In TVs, and everywhere he looked, people seemed to be wealthy. The celebrities on TV wore tens of thousands of dollars worth of watches as though they cost nothing. Ordinary people spent thousands of dollars every month. No, he was in dire straits that he was simply jealous of those who had the luxury of worrying about paying back a thousand-dollar card credit. Those ordinary people. Their ordinary concerns. But such ordinary things were nothing but a fairy tale for Lloyd.

It was obvious. A thousand dollars in credit card debt? Even that was a luxury for me. How starved I was! On bad days, I had to get by with instant ramen.

There was a time when a long monsoon put a pause on a construction project. That was when Lloyd naturally learned the art of surviving with one cup of instant ramen a day. In the morning, he cooked an instant noodle

and ate only the noodle, leaving the soup untouched as much as possible. That was the most important part here. Kill the desire to chug the soup in one go, and that promised him a generous serving of lunch and dinner. Why? It was because he could use the soup again.

For lunch, I cooked the dried noodles offered at the room rental in the ramen soup and only the noodles. Then, for dinner, I mixed in the rice they give out at night with the leftover ramen soup from lunch. This method allowed me to get through the day with one bowl of instant ramen.

Otherwise, he threw an egg and some oil in a large bowl of rice and made fried rice out of it. It was a mess in terms of nutrition, but it was one of the most filling meals out there. It was because of the oil that made the rice greasy and slowed his metabolism.

The downside was that I felt bloated for the rest of the night, but it was better than getting a stomach ache from starving.

The resurfacing memories made his stomach flip over with bitterness. But those miserable days were over for him. The struggle of not having a credit card was nothing but history. It was different now. Why?

“That gold plate... Is that the Padashar, the one that the great and omnipotent sultan bestows...?”

“Yes, it is the one. I am glad that you recognized it right away.”

“Well, of course...”

Gulp. The restaurant owner’s Adam’s apple bobbed visibly, and his eyes, which were buried in fat, observed the gold plate. It was real. It had to be real. The symbol of sultan was engraved in the center of the gold plate. No one could replicate or copy it. It was the absolute law for anyone living under the rule of the sultan.

“So, what do you want to get with the Padashar?” The owner asked Lloyd.

“Everything,” stated Lloyd with a grin.

“Excuse me?”

“I want everything on the menu in this restaurant. Use all the ingredients you have,” demanded Lloyd.

“What are you saying...?”

“Do not think. Just go grill and fry. Consider closing your business for today.”

“Are you telling me to cook your meal using all the ingredients stored for today?”

“Yes, that is what I mean.”

Lloyd smiled in satisfaction. But the restaurant owner’s forehead started to form beads of sweat.

“But as you can see, this is not like any other restaurant. Only the wealthiest in Ahinsya can come in-”

“And that’s why I’m here. With the Padashar bestowed by the great and omnipotent sultan.”

Swish. Swish. Lloyd swayed the gold plate in front of the owner’s eyes, and the latter’s gaze shook.

“Ah... I understand.”

The authority of the Padashar can be trusted, the owner told himself. The sultan would eventually pay him later. Even if he used all the ingredients for today, amounting to an exorbitant bill no ordinary citizen could imagine for one meal, the sultan would pay it all back. So, in a way, this was an opportunity, a golden opportunity to make the most money ever since the restaurant opened.

“Then please wait here for a moment. No, I will escort you personally. Over here.”

Realizing what was going on, the owner dismissed his workers and led Lloyd to the most luxurious room. And he flashed the most courteous smile at Lloyd as though he was looking at a bar of gold.

“So, should I bring all the food to this table?”

“No.”

Lloyd shook his head, and with a carefree smile, he spoke.

“I want you to distribute it to everyone in the restaurant.”

“Excuse me...?”

“Look, I am not a monster. I can’t eat all of that alone. So, bring me one reasonable serving of food. As for the rest, distribute it all to the customers here.”

“But that’s going to-”

“Any reason you can’t?”

“...”

There wasn’t any reason not to. Surely, doing this was an outrageous and irrational way to spend money, but there wasn’t any rule that prevented him from doing so.

“Duly noted.”

The owner hurried into the kitchen and urged the chef and the others. The food came out in no time. Now, Ahinsya was the capital of the sultan’s kingdom and the largest port on the southeastern coast of the continent. So the quality of food was far from ordinary as the restaurant itself was high-end, to say the least. Expensive food continued to be served in series to the point that the table legs shook. Lobster was just the common one. Lamb aged with a 50-year-old wine. Rare jellyfish are caught only in the Arctic. Mushrooms grow only in the deepest part of the cave. Dessert fried from the oil extracted by a flower that blooms every 30 years... Lloyd used his

fork and knife as he heard the chef personally explain each food to him. And Lloyd thought to himself...

Oh, I want to eat soybean paste stew.

Was it because Lloyd preferred simpler food? The chef boasted that his food was gourmet. But Lloyd couldn’t feel that exquisite quality when he tasted them. But still, they were more delicious and filling than he thought. And just like that, he stepped out of the VIP room slapping his belly which had grown slightly chubbier. And he looked around the restaurant with a confident gait, wherein people started to murmur and stare. It was obvious why. Lloyd was the first customer ever to empty the pantry of this high-end, gourmet restaurant in Ahinsya in just one day.

“Everyone,” Lloyd said, his jolly voice echoing through the wide and flashy restaurant. “I am joyful and honored to pay for your meals today. But most of you must be wondering. Why is this man, a total stranger, paying for such an expensive meal for us?”

Everyone nodded their heads. All of them were actually curious. Why on earth is he doing it? What is up with this alien? They used their wildest imaginations but no answer came. They couldn’t wrap their heads around his behavior. The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose slightly.

“There is only one thing I would like to say. May the glory of the great and omnipotent sultan spread everywhere! Yes, that’s right. I am not the one paying for the food here. It’s the sultan’s treat. No, wait, he is paying for the food,” clarified Lloyd, thinking that they won’t know what “treat” meant.

Lloyd then held up the Padashar in his hand, and everyone’s eyes widened in surprise.

“I am sure you know what this object is. Yes, it is the Padashar bestowed by the great and omnipotent sultan. That is right! Every bit of food or sip of drink you enjoy today reflects the grace and consideration of the great and omnipotent sultan. So, let us cheer.”

Lloyd raised the Padashar high. And then...

“Long live the sultan!” Lloyd yelled.

“Long live the sultan...!” Not knowing why, the rich merchants and emirs in the restaurant yelled together.

Lloyd continued to yell, this time louder. “Long live the great and omnipotent sultan!”

“Long live the sultan!”

“Should we,” Lloyd went on, “spend the night partying as we wish for the eternal glory of the great and merciful sultan?”

“Long live the sultan!”

The atmosphere in the restaurant heated up, and on top of the endless buffet of superb food and alcohol, the best of the best bandsmen and dancers were hired. The generous pay guaranteed by the Padashar made them happy. They went an extra mile in their performance, and soon enough, the fanciest restaurant in the capital transformed into a flashy club. And Lloyd was behind the transcendental partying.

Who cares?! It’s not my money anyway!

Is this what it felt like to swipe a VIP card that couldn’t be maxed out? Everything was on the sultan, and there was no limit to its usage. The officials told Lloyd what? Meeting the sultan would take at least six months? Lloyd actually couldn’t be any happier. The opportunity appeared right in front of him, and he meant to grab it hard. So, the next six months would be spent swiping this credit card and shamelessly throwing money down the drain.

Now, this is the sweet life I was talking about!

Lloyd shouted at everyone, “Thank you so much, sultan!”

“Thank you so much!”

The customers in the restaurant and those who just joined after hearing the rumor all roared under the heated atmosphere.

“Our sultan! Our great leader! Our god! We praise you!”

“We praise you!”

The night advanced, equally heating up Lloyd’s unbridled money-spending party.

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A few days later, there was a fuss at the Ahinsya palace. In particular, the palatial high-ranking official’s heart sank.

“What... is this?”

“It’s the credit history of the Padashar used by the Magentano delegation,” replied the official under him.

The high-ranking official’s eyes shook as he looked at the history. “Tell me, are you sure this is the right one?”

There seemed to be an error in the amount. One or two zeros were mistakenly recorded maybe? The high-ranking official hoped a little. This couldn’t be real. It had been only a few days since he handed over the Padashar after mortifying them.

“They splurged this much money in just a few days? That delegation?

He could not believe it, but the response from a low-ranking official was more unbelievable.

“There is no error in the amount. One more thing... It was not used by the whole delegation.”

“Then?”

“It is used independently by one member of the delegation,” said the official.

“What...?”

Just one? Not many? This amount? The high-ranking official’s mouth hung wide open. In a shaking voice, the subordinate spoke.

“I could not believe it at first when I received the history. So, I checked it over two, three times. And then...”

“And?”

“I found out that a member named Lloyd Frontera used the Padashar in various places. He searched for the best of the best restaurants and ordered food and drinks until they ran out of ingredients.”

“Did he eat and drink everything alone?” asked the superior in shock.

“No, he didn’t drink a sip of alcohol, and he shared food with the other customers.”

“To others?” he asked.

“Yes. It is said that he made people praise the sultan by telling them that the food is being paid for by him.”

“Hahaha...”

“It does not end there. He purchased all the silk in the capital, and we discovered that he bought a merchant ship to send every bit of it to the north sea.”

“Silk? To the north sea?”

“The destination is the Cremo port of the Magentano kingdom,” answered the subordinate.

“...”

“It was presumed that it will pass the Cremo port to be finally sent to the Frontera fiefdom...”

“...”

“Furthermore, an extravagant festival is happening every night,” he went on, “And he is purchasing not only silk but also pottery, jewelry, and other valuable items using the Padashar. And he is shipping them to port Cremo...”

“He is shipping them all?”

“Yes. Thanks to him, the palatial budget for this year is...” mumbled the subject.

“It can’t be.”

“...”

“You are not telling me,” the high-ranking official paused, “that we spent the budget already?”

“I am sorry.”

“...”

What kind of weirdo is he? The face of the high-ranking official turned pale as a sheet, and if the report was true, this was a grave matter. No one in the palace imagined such a thing would happen when he offered the Padashar, the grace of the great and omnipotent sultan, to the Magentano envoys. Why? They were the delegation from Queen Magentano and would not dare fall under the grace of the sultan so thoughtlessly. That would be a great shame for them. The official had had no inkling of doubt about it. That was the normal way to think. It was common sense. The natural order of society.

It was beyond his imagination for a loony in the delegation to abuse the Padashar to his heart’s content and act so absurdly. The official jumped to his feet.

“Stay here for a while.”

“Sir? W-where are you going?”

“I must report the matter to the sultan.”

This matter couldn’t be covered up anyway. It had to be reported before it was too late. Something had to be done before it spiraled out of control. So, the official rushed to the palace of the sultan. And later that afternoon, the sultan sent out an order.

“Bring Lloyd Frontera to the palace.”

And just like that, the meeting with the sultan, which was expected to take at least six months, was shortened to a few days. It was all thanks to Lloyd’s unrestrained use of money.

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Chapter 186: Covetous Talent (1)

“I, the son of Arcos Frontera, Lloyd Frontera, am honored to be allowed presence with the great and omnipotent sultan.”

The black marble floor. Gold-clad pillars. Unreachable ceiling. Lloyd’s voice rocketed in that expansive space. Lloyd then strode across the sleek marble floor, passed the pillars, and kneeled and bowed his head at the throne elevated by 16 flights of stairs. But Samarkhan Al Ahinsyad didn’t respond to his greeting. He only stared down at Lloyd with a cool and deep gaze.

Is that him?

Sultan Samarkhan’s eyes shook slightly with complication. Lloyd Frontera. He had heard a lot about him. No, the sultan knew who he was. How could he not? The very Monster Domino operation he had instructed eventually led to the birth of the greatest noble in the Magentano kingdom: Lloyd Frontera.

I thought I could turn the eastern border of Magentano into an irreparable wasteland for at least the next couple of decades.

But he failed. Even though the dozens of fiefdoms were swept away, the smallest one endured and survived, fending off every monster that invaded its territory. Not only that, this fiefdom received tens of thousands of refugees who had lost their homes due to the monsters. And backed by the generous assistance of the Magentano kingdom, the fiefdom then rose to become the hub of reconstruction. Sultan Samarkhan was aware of the man behind such success.

This man was at the epicenter of everything.

Lloyd Frontera. It was because of him. He was the one who defended the Monster Domino. He had turned his fiefdom into the hub of reconstruction by showing many amazing tricks. But that wasn’t the end of his show.

He laid a counterattack to my western border.

The sultan frowned. He couldn't forget the report to this day. A portion of the monsters that were pushed to the Magentano kingdom came back this way, and the defense guards on the border received considerable damage. The one responsible for it was this man, Lloyd Frontera.

Occasionally, no, I frequently got curious. Without fail, the many reports I received on this subject intrigued me. I wondered how great this man was. Whether his reputation was exaggerated or not. But as I see him now... He is more brazen than I expected.

Just then, he recalled what had happened earlier in the day. A high-ranking official in charge of the palace scurried into the hall and reported the matter.

How dare he abuse my Padashar and resort to such wasteful extravagance.

The sultan was caught off-guard, too. Could it be that this alien had no sense of shame? Or was he just gutsy? Or was this a blatant act of protest? The Padashar symbolized the holistic favor from the sultan, and initially, it was to be used with care in eternal gratitude to the sultan. Or it was to bring the recipient great humiliation, knowing they were being belittled by their enemy.

What is going on inside that man's head that he dared to act this way? How could he remain calm after being summoned here?

The sultan felt baffled. After observing Lloyd for a while, the sultan finally spoke.

"Lloyd Frontera."

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"Did you enjoy it?" The sultan asked.

"Your Majesty?"

“I am asking whether you enjoyed rashly using the Padashar to your heart’s content.”

“Why, yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd said. “Truly and sincerely, I enjoyed it very much.”

“That much...?”

“Long live the sultan! Long live the sultan!”

“...”

Lloyd practically put his head to the ground and yelled aloud, which made the sultan clamp his mouth shut. The sultan had expected Lloyd to feel at least a little embarrassed. It never occurred to him that Lloyd would be so joyful to be under the grace of the sultan.

“How surprising. Are you not afraid that you will now be doubted by Queen Magentano?” asked the sultan.

“By doubt, may I inquire what you mean, Your Majesty?”

“That you are trying to betray your kingdom by earning my favor. You neither rejected nor were unreserved in receiving a favor from an enemy kingdom. No, you didn’t even hesitate to show your joy and gratitude. Are you not worried?”

“No, Your Majesty. I am not.”

“How?”

“For Queen Magentano has spent more money on me than Your Majesty,” stated Lloyd coolly.

“...”

“It is with regret to inform you that the money you have bestowed on me is far lesser than what I received. However, Your Majesty, do not worry. This

humble man is eternally grateful for the grace that was generously bestowed on me."

"Ha! What a brazen-faced fellow you are."

The sultan burst into laughter at the absurdity of his attitude. But strangely, the sultan didn't dislike him very much. The reason was simple. The sultan had lived in the center of the palace, so his whole life was surrounded by cunning and sly people trying to butter him up. Countless groveling officials attempted to please him around the clock to earn his favor and grace. They were like a bunch of power-hungry flies, and those two-faced officials always sucked up to him. But what Lloyd just said was not flattery. The sultan could see that clearly.

He is truly shameless and strange. How dare he utter such words without any ulterior motive in my presence?

The sultan couldn't spot an iota of pretense in Lloyd's words. Everything that the man said came from his genuine heart. That truly amazed the sultan.

"What if I bestow you with more gold and treasure? Are you willing to change the flag you are loyal to?"

Like poking a new toy or mole cricket on the ground, the sultan asked as he twitched his lip. He was excited to hear the other man's answer. Lloyd didn't disappoint him.

"Please forgive this humble man for saying this to Your Majesty, the great and omnipotent sultan, but permit me to inquire whether you wish to have a man who changes his allegiance so easily under your command."

"Ha?"

"I like gold and treasure in all honesty," went on Lloyd, "Rather than like, I love them. Should Your Majesty guarantee endless riches to me, my heart would waver at the offer, to be honest. However, this humble man is aware

that changing my allegiance at the drop of a hat will only work to lose Your Majesty's trust."

"Hmm," mused the sultan. "You wish to change your allegiance, but that will only make me lose my trust in you?"

"Yes, Your Majesty. Therefore, the flag of temptation that Your Majesty sways right now will be unattainable in this lifetime."

"Tsk... How cunning you are."

The sultan then chuckled in amusement. Lloyd Frontera. He was truly a talent the sultan desired to keep. This man managed to put a brake on the sultan's plans. That was how capable he was. Plus, he was cherished by Queen Magentano. As such, recruiting him would be helpful in many ways.

But if he changes his allegiance for a couple of gold coins... I would be equally disappointed.

Such a chameleon like that couldn't be used regardless of one's competence. That was why the sultan tested him out, but it looked like the young man already saw through his intentions.

That is why I want him all the more.

The sultan was pleased. He became greedier. But his covet had to end here. Now, it was time to get to the core of why he had called Lloyd here.

"I see, then I have a question to ask you. I presume you wanted to meet me?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"That is why you used the Padashar to your heart's content?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

Lloyd nodded his head. It was true. He had whipped out the Padashar at every store with a plan in mind, and it served a clear purpose. Right now,

when the delegation was being ignored so explicitly, Lloyd figured the most efficient way to draw the sultan's attention was this.

That's why I didn't hold back on spending. But it turned out to be much better than I thought. This is why you have to make good friends.

Lloyd recalled the events of a few days ago. Even though he boasted the money to follow his plan, he truly enjoyed doing it. That was his first time spending so much money. Along the way, he learned the important lesson of why people were obsessed with money.

That was the reason why people always said that we've got to make good friends. Like how they said that we must be friends with those who try to buy friendship, that we must keep such people on our side for life.

Such friends were helpful in many ways. If possible, such friendships were to be maintained with great passion and care. Case in point, the sultan in front of Lloyd was that kind of friend. Marking that lesson in his heart, Lloyd carefully spoke.

"Please forgive me for saying this, Your Majesty, my actions were my desperate entreaty for Your Majesty, the great and omnipotent sultan, to sit at the negotiation table with us."

"Me? Negotiate with your delegation?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"How so?"

"For the war will bring misfortune to everyone," said Lloyd, his voice ringing aloud in the air.

The sultan rolled up a corner of his lips. "I do not see it that way."

"Your Majesty?"

"Why would a war bring misery? I just need to win."

“In other words, is Your Majesty confident that victory will be yours once the war breaks out against the Magentano kingdom?”

“It is not that,” replied the sultan, his smile deepening.

“There is no such thing as guaranteed victory in this world. I am not foolish enough to believe that. However, what I am confident is that the war against the Magentano kingdom would never be a loss for my kingdom.”

“Could you mean...”

“What a nice expression you are wearing right now. Have you realized my intentions already?”

“Is your plan to shift the panic inside the kingdom to the outside?” theorized Lloyd.

“I knew it. I have a good eye for people.”

“...”

Lloyd clamped his mouth shut. Pushing the internal chaos outside? Overcoming political conflict using a foreign enemy? This was a classic tactic countless rulers had resorted to throughout the earth’s history. Lloyd quickly racked his head.

There must be a conflict in this kingdom. Something chaotic. And he is trying to use war against Magentano to cover it up or solve it. What could that be? Think. Think. Come on brain, you can do it!

Lloyd searched through his memory, trying to remember the stories in the novel. He went through every buried memory of his. And soon, he was hit with something.

Drought.

It must have been around the time Javier was traversing the sultan’s kingdom in the novel. There was an episode about Javier passing a location suffering from a prolonged drought. The resentful local residents vented to

Javier that this place had become unlivable due to drought and everyone was about to perish. Yet the sultan cared nothing about it. All he cared for was the riches of Ahinsya, the capital. That was why they planned on revolting. Bring down the sultan, and open a new era. The powerful emirs in the regions resonated with such sentiment.

Eventually, a large-scale revolt broke out. Then it led to a civil war that lasted for several years.

The civil war ended with the sultan getting defeated. And he jumped off from the top of the spire of the Ahinsya palace enclosed in several layers of protestors. That was what was written in *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

In other words, the sultan will risk losing his power if he stays put.

Of course, it could be different from the novel. The event's exact timeline and scale could change, just like the Namaran incident. But judging by the sultan's attitude now...

There's a chance for a revolt. That's why he isn't against going to war with the Magentano kingdom. He's trying to use the war to silence the public's complaints and shift their attention elsewhere. And the prolonged drought is the main cause of this unrest.

At last, the puzzles pieced together in his head. Wage a war. Conscript men in the regions. The families and elderly would have no power to raise a revolt. All they could hope for is that their sons, husbands, and fathers in the war would return safely. Moreover, the special circumstance, which arose from the war, helped the sultan for the better.

The people wouldn't be able to express their dissatisfaction, and anybody who grumbled and protested could be framed as traitors and rats who work for the enemy. They'd know that stirring up internal conflict would only make things worse during war times, harming their family members out on the battlefield. Those anxious thoughts and worries would work against their anti-kingdom sentiments.

That's how the sultan will keep tight control over the people. He's trying to forcibly unite everyone.

Lloyd nodded as he imagined the scenario in his head, like what intentions the sultan had and what he was faced with. If that was the case... Lloyd thought he could throw bait to the sultan.

"However," Lloyd said, "I would like to dare say that the drought is not something that can be covered up easily with a war."

"What...?"

Lloyd's words made the sultan's eyebrows twitch. But he had already set how the conversation should take off.

"I ask for your generous forgiveness, Your Majesty, but I cannot bear the thought of Your Majesty in trouble when you have been so kind and generous to this lowly existence."

"I will be in trouble...?" asked the sultan.

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"Explain."

"Your Majesty, consider with your generosity with what I am-"

"Omit the lip service."

Was it because Lloyd was able to pinpoint so easily that the problem was the drought? The sultan maintained a straight face and wasn't smiling at all. But this was not so bad. At last, the negotiation table opened up. Sensing so, Lloyd spoke.

"I will be straightforward as Your Majesty ordered of me. I have heard that the Kandahar region is suffering from a prolonged drought. Am I correct?"

"Yes."

“If I solve the drought that continuously plagues the Kandahar region, will Your Majesty grant my wish and entertain the Magentano delegation?”

“What...?”

The sultan’s beard twitched.

“You can solve the drought?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“You can solve a drought that has even dried up the oasis? You can do that?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“How?”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty, but I cannot answer that until Your Majesty agrees to my terms.”

“How so?” asked the sultan.

Lloyd looked up at last. Attempting to appear extremely polite, wearing the I-don’t-have-a-choice look on his face, making sure that his rich client would not be offended, Lloyd spoke, his voice and eyes wretchedly desperate.

“It is a trade secret.”

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Chapter 187: Covetous Talent (2)

“It is a trade secret.”

“Ha?”

Though Lloyd’s answer was jolly, it was never rude. Though his voice was light, his face was desperate. The same went for his pleading gaze that darted toward the sultan. His eyes were glossy. Just then, the sultan seemed to feel those emotions coming from him.

“I am dying to tell it to you, but spilling out my trade secret here so recklessly is going to make me lose my job and throw me to the streets forever, so please, please, let it slide, oh, my dear heavenly client, with your generosity.”

“Hahahaha!”

The sultan broke into laughter. It was too dumbfounding that the very man he thought was a loony was gazing at him like that. And Lloyd’s reckless answer stood so much contrast with his begging eyes. It was so dumbfounding that the sultan started to feel amazed.

Where did this brazen-faced fellow come from?

The sultan was amazed. This man was competent. He knew he was competent and when to use his skills at the right time. But he never went out of line, depending on his skills. Staying within the line, he freakishly kept just the right amount of impertinence. He knew how to portray himself as bold without getting on the superior’s nerves. That was the impression the sultan received from Lloyd from this encounter and his answers. Avarice swelled over his eyes toward Lloyd.

That makes him more desirable.

Suddenly, the sultan became envious of Queen Magentano for having such a man under her. If only he could, he wanted to steal Lloyd away and put

him under his command. The sultan yearned to enjoy the look the queen would make when she realized that her talent was stolen from her.

“Haha, a trade secret! Hahahaha!”

The sultan, who was looking down at Lloyd, smiled and tossed Lloyd a question as though he was watching his grandson dance and play around.

“Do you mean that you will only spill the secret to solve the drought when I agree to your terms?” asked the sultan.

“Please forgive me, Your Majesty, but it is the case, oh, great and omnipotent sultan.”

“Hmm... How impudent and reckless you are. Are you not afraid that my wrath may have you beheaded?”

“I am afraid, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd, “I am afraid well enough.”

“Then how can you dare say those words?”

“It’s because I have no doubts about your grace and mercy, Your Majesty.”

“Haha. Now you are flattering the leader of your enemy.”

“My words are not mere flattery, Your Majesty. They are the truth.”

“How so?” asked the sultan.

“How can it be flattery when I am risking my life?”

Indeed. It was a gamble of its own. Though Lloyd was gambling because he saw a chance of success, he was nonetheless risking himself by having the sultan as his opponent.

The one who loses more by the drought is the sultan, not me.

Sure, the sultan claimed that the war would be the solution because people’s attention would naturally shift and be distracted. But what would the sultan

really feel deep down?

He won't be as relaxed as he portrays himself to be.

He had to be racking his brain every night for a solution to solve the drought. Not a band-aid solution like war. A solution that got to the root of the problem. He must have contemplated hard but failed to arrive at one.

That's why he is trying to use war as a distraction for the issue.

This was primarily the reason why Lloyd was convinced that the sultan would react to his suggestion of solving the drought problem. Moreover, Lloyd actually had a solution to the drought.

"Good... I am glad that you regard me in such a manner. I shall then take up your offer."

"That means..."

"Lloyd Frontera, find the solution to the drought, and I will give you what you want," said the sultan solemnly.

"Do you mean the term that Your Majesty will negotiate with the Magentano delegation?"

"Indeed. Although I cannot guarantee a certain outcome."

"This humble man asks no more than that, Your Majesty."

The negotiation was a matter the delegation had to resolve on its own. All Lloyd could do was put everyone at the same table, and he had no plans to do more than that.

"If that's the case, I am sure you can speak now. Your trade secret," urged the sultan.

"Why, yes, Your Majesty."

Lloyd bowed deeply. The sultan just gave the nod to Lloyd. And so, from that moment, the sultan was his client, more valuable and precious than any king in the world. Ready to serve his client, Lloyd spoke.

“I heard that the underground water in the Kandahar region often dries up from any decrease in rainfall due to the lack of oases in the area. Am I correct, Your Majesty?”

“Indeed,” confirmed the sultan. “So, what is your solution to drought?”

“It is Qanat.”

“Qanat?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“I have never heard of it. I need an explanation,” requested the sultan as he stared at Lloyd.

“It is a water supply system used by various ancient desert kingdoms.”

“Ancient desert kingdoms?” The mention of the desert kingdom made the sultan’s brows quirk up.

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd paused before continuing his eloquent explanation. “In the ancient kingdom named ‘Persia,’ this facility was called ‘Qanat.’ And in the nearby regions of Pakistan and Afghanistan, it was called ‘Karez.’ In Morocco, it was called ‘Lettara.’ And in Northern Africa, it was called ‘Foggara.’ The names varied, but it was all the same kind of system.”

It was true. Although Persia didn’t belong to this realm of the world, it was nonetheless a kingdom in the ancient past. And it was also true that Qanat had many names depending on the region. Moreover, it is still being utilized on earth in modern days.

“Thus, the principle is all the same,” Lloyd said as he continued his explanation that was endless as a fountain. “Since deserts are naturally hot and dry, the water running along the earth evaporates before it reaches the

villages and cities. As such, the water must flow through a cold underground tunnel to draw it out effectively."

"I believe so. But there must be a limit to using underground water."

"Undoubtedly, Your Majesty."

It really was the case. In fact, the underground water of the desert was barely reliable. It was also the case for the oasis, which many people here regarded as the hope of the desert. Why? Not to mention the small water volume there, it was infected with a host of germs and fatal viruses as it was shared with not only the humans but also the other creatures, including the bacteria. Furthermore, the underground water and oasis tended to have too much sodium, unlike other bodies of water. In short, the water wasn't potable until it was boiled and distilled due to its germs and sodium.

"So," Lloyd said, "the underground waterway of Qanat must never touch the existing underground vein of water. This is to ensure that the clean water of Qanat will not mix with the contaminated and salty underground water."

"The clean water of Qanat..." mused the sultan before speaking."Where do we draw such clean water if not from underground?"

"From the foot of a faraway mountain."

"Foot of a mountain?"

"Yes, Your Majesty." Lloyd nodded his head. "I have heard that a tall mountain range stands on the outskirts of the Kandahar region. And that the foot of the mountain range teems with water melted by the permanent snow at the peak."

"Are you possibly suggesting that you can draw that water through an underground passage to the Kandahar region?"

"That is exactly the case, Your Majesty."

"That is a tremendous distance. Can you do it?"

“It is my job as your humble servant to make that possible,” answered Lloyd confidently.

The sultan frowned as he looked at Lloyd.

“I wonder if that really is possible. The mountain is dozens of miles from here. Moreover, where did you acquire such wisdom? You say Persia of the ancient desert kingdom. However, I have never heard of that name before.” The sultan’s voice was filled with doubt.

“It was a coincidence that I came across a nameless book in an old library, Your Majesty.”

“An old book?” asked the sultan.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Hmm... Is that so? To be frank, I am not sure I could trust your knowledge and source of wisdom. However, I will trust you, given your accomplishments and reputation in the Magentano kingdom. The results of the construction will verify your mastery anyway.”

“Your Majesty, do you mean you will leave the construction to this humble peasant?”

“Yes.” The sultan nodded before speaking on. “Do find the solution to the drought in the Kandahar through the Qanat you mentioned a while ago. Should your construction end in success, I will sit at the negotiation table with the Magentano envoys as I promised.”

The sultan’s declaration was made forth, and Lloyd bowed in sheer gratitude.

“Words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Majesty. Pray, may I borrow a paper and pen for just a moment here?”

“A paper and pen?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” answered Lloyd

“What use will they serve?”

“To create a construction contract, Your Majesty.”

“A construction contract?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd answered.

The sultan’s furrow deepened. “You dare write a contract? With me?”

“Please forgive me, but yes, Your Majesty.”

“That will be unnecessary,” defied the sultan with a curt reply. “I am aware of the importance of a contract. But it is a meaningless piece of paper to me, regardless of how great it is. Have you forgotten where you are? Have you got no sense of which land you are stepping on?” The sultan continued to speak with gravitas. “This is my palace, and all the land in this desert is in the palm of my hands and belongs to me. Here, one word from my mouth holds more legitimacy than hundreds or thousands of paper contracts.”

“However...”

“Do you mean you dare not trust my promise?” warned the sultan.

“Certainly not, Your Majesty,” Lloyd said, his voice almost pleading.

“Then what is the reason behind your stubbornness?”

“Since I distrust myself, Your Majesty.”

“What...?” The scowl on the sultan’s face relaxed a little. Lloyd continued to speak.

“I ask for your mercy, Your Majesty, for saying this, but how would I dare distrust the great and omnipotent sultan? If it’s coming from Your Majesty’s mouth, I would believe that sand can be turned into gold and sand can be made from boiled water. The question is, does Your Majesty have enough trust in me?”

“What is it that you wish to speak?”

“I wish to say that a contract is mutual, Your Majesty.”

“Mutual, you say.”

“Yes, Your Majesty. Thus, it is important to have a written contract. What if I break the terms made with Your Majesty? What if I trick Your Majesty and half-heartedly construct the Qanat so that it only works for a short time after its completion?”

“Are you implying that you will do a flimsy job?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. I have the capacity to do so.”

“Haha. How daring you are to say that out loud.”

“I am simply speaking of the possibilities, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd bowed his head lower.

“Should I develop any bad intentions, what I said could fully happen. I could cheat and deceive Your Majesty only to fulfill the goal of opening up a negotiation for the envoys. It is true that a part of me is tempted to do so. That is why-”

“Writing the contract will prevent such from happening,” the sultan said as he finished Lloyd’s words.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

That was how crucial contracts were. Lloyd held a plethora of experience working in construction. And so, he recognized this fact from the depths of his soul.

I can’t do anything without a contract. There are countless problems that arise even for constructions with a contract.

It really was the case. Avoiding responsibility for any change in design. Construction halted due to lien conflict. Such issues and conflicts were common in construction sites. That was even when the contracts were signed. And without them? All hell broke loose.

“Therefore, please forgive this humble servant when he says that writing a construction contract is a must. This is not because I cannot trust you but to prove that Your Majesty can be rest assured in leaving the project in my hands,” said Lloyd, carefully choosing his words.

“Hmm.”

Lloyd was still lying flat on his belly, bowing. The sultan wore an incomprehensible expression as he looked at Lloyd’s back.

What a strange man.

This man spoke only the right things, and yet, they didn’t sound annoying in his ears. The sultan faintly could know why.

He is being considerate. He dares to be considerate of me.

This man named Lloyd was nothing but a successor of a county in a foreign land. And yet, he was being considerate toward this very sultan, the ruler of the vast desert. The sultan could feel it from his careful words and actions. Lloyd’s attitude could be likened to a salesman delicately helping out a customer coming to the store for the first time. He was helping out in a way that would not make them uncomfortable and ensure a wise choice. His considerate guidance and assistance were both offensive and commendable to the sultan.

How dare he treat me this way… Should I be angry or grateful? Goodness.

At last, the sultan simply scoffed and granted Lloyd’s request. The two wrote the construction contract and signed it. Once the work was done and Lloyd left, the sultan pondered for a long time. And that night, he called one of his daughters to the palace. He had dozens of daughters from many

wives, but this one was his favorite due to her bold character and way with swords.

“You called for me, Father.”

“I did. My dear daughter, Sheherazade. I wish to entrust you with a job. From now on, act as a guard for a man named Lloyd Frontera, who will be dispatched to the Kandahar region. Blend in naturally and accompany him.”

“Simply guard him, Father?” the daughter asked. “Anything else that I must do?”

“Make him yours.”

“Your Majesty...?” For a split second, Sheherazade’s eyes shook.

“Resort to every means possible. You can suppress him with your sword. Or find a fault in him and use it to your advantage. Do anything it takes to make him your man and come back to Ahinsya.”

“Does that mean-”

“Indeed. He shall be my son-in-law.”

This Lloyd person was more desirable than the sultan had expected. Previously, the sultan simply wanted to have Lloyd. It was just vague greed. But today’s encounter changed his heart. Lloyd Frontera. The sultan had a feeling that his kingdom’s future would take on a different path the moment he had Lloyd as his son-in-law.

“We must have him on our side no matter what.”

Sultan Samarkhan recalled Lloyd, and his eyes held a deep glint of greed and longing toward the talent.

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Chapter 188: A Greedy Man’s Charity (1)

The past few days were a repeat of the same routine for Lloyd. After dinner, he hopped on the camel’s back and was rocked on and on as the animal trudged ahead. The similar desert scenery spanned before him all day. And when the moon went westward to give way to the morning, he got down from the camel, had breakfast half-asleep, and crept into the camp installed under the shade for sleep. And when the night came, he got on the camel’s back again. Just like that, every day was the same, and the pattern only broke a few days later when the regular desert scenery was replaced with a new one.

“We are now in Kandara, the central city of Kandahar.”

“…”

Lloyd’s ears perked up at Sheherazade’s words. She was the female bodyguard the sultan personally assigned to him.

“Have we now arrived at our destination?” asked Lloyd joyfully.

“You could say that,” replied Sheherazade.

“Woah.”

Lloyd drew in a breath. He was finally here. He welcomed the arrival and was happy.

Goodbye to riding on the camel for a while.

All of a sudden, his thoughts flew back to the events a few days ago. It must have been a day after he signed the construction contract with the sultan in Ahinsya. He received the people the sultan sent and hurried to leave for Kandahar. And along the way, he quickly explained the situation to the delegation, who was befuddled as to what was happening. Just like that, Lloyd hurried and left Ahinsya, and the days that followed made Lloyd feel as though he was undergoing an Antarctic expedition.

I did hear that the desert gets cold at night, but I never thought it'd be this bad.

Lloyd shivered. Desert. Camel. Anyone would associate those words with the searing heat. The same thing went on in Lloyd's head when he was to leave for Kandahar and when he left the capital. He expected to traverse through the scorching desert and worried that he had no sunblock with him. But his worry turned out to be unnecessary and foolish. The journey took off in direct contrast to his expectations.

When it was boiling hot outside, we set up a camp under the shade. And when the sun set, we moved through the night.

When the sun was gone from the sky, the temperature in the desert plummeted along with his happiness. It was cold. Terribly cold. How painful the gust of wind was! It was so biting that Lloyd was reminded of the winter training during his military years. He missed the old long padded coats he used to wear in South Korea.

Anyway, goodbye to such a cold for a while since I've safely arrived.

Lloyd never liked cold things to begin with. So, the mere fact that he could avoid being in it gladdened him.

"Then are we staying here for a while?"

Sheherazade nodded her head at Lloyd's question.

"Yes," she answered, "Over here. Allow me to escort you to our quarters"

"Oh, excuse me. Then..."

"Do you have any questions?"

"Even at the lodging, will Miss…" asked Lloyd.

"You can call me Sheherazade."

“Oh, then Miss Sheherazade. Will you be guarding me in the lodging as well?”

“That is right,” she said plainly.

“Ack. Are we using the same room?”

“That is correct, too.”

“...”

“What is wrong?” asked Sheherazade. She was staring at Lloyd hard, and her dark-pearly eyes made him uncomfortable. Lloyd decided to be frank and expressed his sentiments to her as he smiled wryly.

“I feel slightly uncomfortable. In any case, you are a woman.”

“I am all right,” she said.

“I... don’t feel all right.”

His wry smile deepened.

“I wish to be comfortable in my room. I want to change in peace as well and be less self-conscious. But if you stay with me, then-”

“But the great and omnipotent sultan left your safety in my hands,” opposed Sheherazade adamantly.

“Sir Asrahan can protect me very well if you are concerned about my safety,” argued Lloyd as he glanced at Javier.

“...”

Sheherazade’s glance moved toward the silver-hair knight, Javier.

“As I introduced to you on the day of our departure,” Lloyd explained, “he has been protecting me since I was at the fiefdom. He is Sir Javier Asrahan. He may have his share of shortcomings, such as his snobby attitude,

inclination to hurt people with his cold words, and a face that's slightly more good-looking than mine, but he nonetheless is a useful guy when it comes to guarding."

"I am aware," replied Sheherazade. "It is an honor to be with the young sword master everyone talks about. But it appears that he is much more handsome than you, not a little."

"Mhm... Okay. Anyway, Sir Asrahan is here," Lloyd said, deciding not to dwell on that.

"So what?" she asked.

"Please leave my protection to Sir Asrahan in my room."

"Are you forcing me to go against the order of the great and omnipotent sultan?" She stared at Lloyd hard as she said those words.

"Uhm, no. That's not it."

Lloyd was flustered. Was it because of Sheherazade's adamant attitude? Surely, it was one reason. But there was a greater factor.

That sultan guy is more shameless than I pegged him to be. Seriously. How can he so boldly send his own daughter as my bodyguard?

Sheherazade. The sultan had told Lloyd that she was an excellent bodyguard. Though a woman, she was an unrivaled sword fighter. So, stay rest assured, the sultan urged Lloyd, adding that her acute sword skills and attention to detail would promise him the best protection. The sultan personally complimented her and assigned her to him. But Lloyd wasn't fooled because he had already read The Knight of Blood and Iron, which detailed that the sultan had a daughter named Sheherazade. Not only that, she was one of the ones that tried to protect the captured tower right before the sultan took his own life. She was also the best female sword fighter in the desert. Thanks to her skills, she had the freedom to leave the palace at a young age compared to the rest of the princesses that had to stay within the palace their whole life. Her skills were honed and mastered under the

special permission of the sultan. But according to the novel, no one aside from the sultan and his close cohorts knew that she was his daughter.

That must be why she's using her real name. There's no way for anyone to presume her real identity. More so for me as I'm a foreigner.

Generally speaking, the princesses in the desert were hidden behind a veil. Their faces and names were tightly kept a secret within the walls of the palace.

But too bad. I read the novel. I recognized that she was the sultan's daughter from the moment he introduced her to me.

The sultan who assigned his own daughter to protect him. The daughter who insisted on staying in the same room as him. Lloyd could vaguely make out what was happening.

Oh, again. Again! I can feel it. l can sense what's happening.

Lloyd Frontera! Be my son-in-law! Lloyd seemed to hear the sultan shout that at him. This wasn't something Lloyd experienced for the first time.

This happened in Cremo. "Will you be my son-in-law?" And in Namaran. "Do marry my daughter." I might have heard the same thing if the queen had a daughter. "You. Take my daughter."Woah. And now, the enemy country's sultan is one of my candidates for a father-in-law.

Lloyd couldn't believe it. It looked like the daughters barely had any interest in him. And yet, he was wildly popular with his candidates for father-in-law.

Am I popular among elderly men?

As the epiphany hit him, his eyes started to well up with sad tears. But Lloyd laughed it off with resignation in secret and looked at Sheherazade.

"Yes. I'm asking you to go against his command," said Lloyd.

"..."

“Don’t worry,” Lloyd added. “I can always fabricate that you did protect me when I go back to Ahinsya and tell the sultan. That you stayed by my side night and day.”

“Surely-”

“Please don’t say you can’t,” interrupted Lloyd.

“...”

“I am a mid-level sword expert. In other words, you don’t have to stick your neck out for me.”

“But I am-”

“Yes,” said Lloyd, cutting in again, “You are a high-level sword expert. So, your senses must be extremely heightened. But what to do? I told you. This knight over here is a sword master.”

“...”

“Here’s the thing. Once you prove that you can guard better than a sword master, then you and I can stay in the same room. But if that’s not the case, I want the right to be free in my lodging. And I don’t want to impose on you.”

“Are you serious about that?”

“Yes, every word,” said Lloyd without a hint of concession.

“...”

The dark pearly eyes of Sheherazade shook. Tears? No. They were embers of rage. That pleased Lloyd.

Good. Hate me more.

Sheherazade must hate me, Lloyd told himself. That was the best way to sabotage the sultan’s plan to make Lloyd his son-in-law. Why? Lloyd had

no interest in this princess and the sultan in the first place.

All I want is to laze around the rest of my life, enjoying the abundance and ordinariness of life.

Just like that, Lloyd grinned wide, his heart burning with a desire as hot as a cup of black coffee. He fixed his eyes on her, unabashedly receiving her glare. Lloyd shrugged and put an end to the matter.

“Then please take me to my room. Of course, you should look for your own room after.”

The princess wheeled around, saying nothing further, and she walked toward the lodging just like Lloyd asked. There was something rough about her gesture now, but Lloyd didn’t care. Just like that, he was led to his room, and he quickly unpacked his stuff and immediately tried to leave with Javier lest Sheherazade tag along. But he failed.

“Were you planning to leave me behind?” Sheherazade demanded.

“Uh... Um, hahaha.”

Sheherazade was standing in the corridor of his room. Could it be that she saw this coming? It appeared so.

Smiling awkwardly, Lloyd asked, “Have you been waiting here for long?”

“No, not really. I just arrived,” she replied.

“Do you plan on accompanying me from now on?”

“Yes, of course.”

That was exactly the problem, Lloyd thought to himself.

I can’t be bothered.

Lloyd wished to lose her if that was an option. It was particularly so as he had to get cracking with the surveying.

I don’t want to have her glued to me like this. It’s uncomfortable.

It didn’t matter whether she was really trying to protect him or simply using the sultan’s order to get close to him. Either way, she made Lloyd uncomfortable. He didn’t have any plans to be friends with her in the first place. Moreover, her presence would only disturb him when he was surveying the site.

I’m used to Javier because he’s been with me for a long time. He makes sure that he doesn’t stand in my way when he senses that I’m surveying the area after meticulously sensing my gaze.

But Sheherazade was inexperienced. She would barely know what surveying would be like. So, it was better for him to expect nothing from her.

That’s not happening.

Lloyd yearned to quickly finish the construction so that the negotiation would happen between the sultan and the envoys. That way, he could return to the Frontera fiefdom, the place where the second chapter of life would truly begin.

So, I have to construct Qanat quickly. Surveying? I have to finish it up, pronto.

But what would happen if someone hovered around him and bothered his work? It would cause a delay, His return to the Frontera fiefdom and life of prosperity would be equally delayed.

Never. I refuse.

Lloyd shook his head in his heart and put his brain to work. What would be the best excuse to leave her here? Order Javier to knock her out? Lock her up?

No. No, that’s too harsh. What if she tells her father? Son-in-law and construction whatnot, he might kill me without a second thought.

Lloyd shivered as his shoulders felt cold. At last, he came up with a brilliant idea.

“Miss Sheherazade, may we have a word?” suggested Lloyd.

“What about?”

“Something that must be discussed indoors. Would you mind coming in for a minute?”

Lloyd grinned as he led her inside her room. Curiosity appeared in her eyes because she remembered how he loathed being in the same room with her. But now, he suggested that she enter as there was something to discuss.

“...”

She entered, and along the way, she saw. She saw Lloyd hinting at Javier with his gaze to stay outside and wait.

Hmm...

As she was led inside the room and sat on the sofa at Lloyd’s urge, she furrowed a little. Just then, the sultan’s order hit her. He had wanted to have this man as his son-in-law. So, she was to resort to any means possible to make him hers. Even foul play was allowed.

“...”

The opportunity to make it happen came earlier than expected. This was the moment to have a private conversation without interruption or disruption. Sensing it in her bones, Sheherazade resolved to her that the chance to prove to his father was now here. And now, she could make up for the resentment of not being born as a prince.

Only if I could make that man mine.

She would accept any friendly conversations. Thinking so, she looked at Lloyd, her gaze and expression ready to respond to him amiably, to break the ice, and to earn his favor. She was all set. Just then...

"For concrete, we will use high-strength concrete with high compressive strength to improve adhesion with PSC materials and reduce cross-sectional dimensions, and to this end, do preferably reduce the water-cement ratio (W/C) and improve workability."

Eh...?

Lloyd spoke, but what came out of his mouth was some unexpected, incomprehensible gibberish in her ears.

What is this... She wanted to ask. What are you doing?! But she couldn’t.

"Maximum dimensions of the thick aggregate used during the production of PSCs will be determined by the tight concrete filling around PS steel, sheath, rebars, etc., and should average around 20 mm or 25 mm."

“...”

Dazed. Sheherazade suddenly felt blank, light. She was definitely listening to his words, but strangely, her eyes felt heavy.

It’s strange.

Could it be because she lacked sleep? She had been struggling with severe insomnia since becoming a high-level sword expert. Her senses grew too sensitive toward all the sounds around her. She had endured solely with her willpower. Could it be the reason why? Could it be that she forgot what it felt like to have a good night's sleep? Could it be why this unexpected drowsiness felt so welcoming?

I shouldn’t... fall asleep now...

Her body felt light. And her ears continued to enjoy the strange spell, which sounded like music from heaven.

“It is recommended that the compressive strength of concrete when pre-stress is introduced into the secondary material is 350 kgf/cm squared or higher in pretension and 300 kgf/cm squared in port tension. In both ways... What the... Must be at least 1.7 times the maximum introduction stress...

Blah blah blah The compressive strength on the 28th... Yada yada yada... It must be 350 kgf/cm squared in the pre-tensioning member... Blah blah...” And with that, she passed out. She was now soundly sleeping after being unable to fight against sleep no more. A smile of satisfaction appeared on Lloyd’s mouth.

Operation Lose the Princess? Success! Hope you have a long, sweet dream. I’ll come back soon!

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Chapter 189: A Greedy Man’s Charity (2)

“Have you succeeded?”

“Hm? Yeah,” said Lloyd, realizing what Javier meant.

“Is she sound asleep?”

“Pretty much.”

“Are you happy?”

“Very much.” Lloyd scoffed.

Quietly shutting the door behind him, Lloyd winked at Javier. The operation was a success. Sheherazade. The daughter of the sultan and an excellent swordswoman. The novel described her as a high-level sword expert. And that was accurate based on the signs Lloyd had observed throughout their journey to Kandara. She couldn’t get any sleep. Tossing and turning with every minute, even the softest blow of the wind made her ears twitch. Seeing that every day, Lloyd was certain.

She’s experiencing sword master syndrome.

Lloyd was certain. She was acting much like the first time Lloyd saw Javier. The syndrome referred to when someone’s senses grew extremely sensitive as they became a high-level sword master. However, since they weren’t a sword master yet, they became tortured by the lack of control they had over their senses. That was what the sword master syndrome was, and Sheherazade was going through exactly that.

I never saw her sleeping for more than ten minutes since we left Ahinsya.

As such, her eyes were slightly bloodshot at all times. They reminded Lloyd of when he gave up sleeping under the crushing burden of his construction job and school work in South Korea. So, he resorted to his ultimate game plan, the lullaby. The result was highly satisfactory.

“She’s sound asleep,” Lloyd said, “It should be her first time falling asleep like this. It’ll probably be tomorrow until she wakes up as she catches up on all the sleep she missed. Much like you used to.”

Lloyd spoke, then flashed an evil smile, looking back to the first time he put Javier to sleep. Could it be that Javier thought the same thing?

“Is that so?” asked Javier. But his face was sterner than before.

“Yeah, uh-huh.”

“So, are you happy?” asked Javier again.

“Hmm?”

“Never mind. If you got what you want, let us proceed,” dismissed Javier. With that, he wheeled around coldly and walked ahead along the corridor that led outside. But something about his back seemed strange. His gait was slightly faster than usual, and there was a roughness in his movement, though menial. The others wouldn’t have noticed it, but Lloyd, who almost always stuck to Javier all day, was able to catch the slight difference right away.

Hmm? Could he be...

Lloyd could sense it. Then he grinned. With a naughty smile on his face, he strode ahead and got closer to Javier, who was marching across the corridor.

“Hey, tell me. Are you sulking by any chance?” asked Lloyd.

“I am not sure what you mean,” denied Javier.

“I think you’re sulking. Right? You are upset about something, aren’t you?”

“No,” Javier denied once again. “I have no complaints of any sort.”

“Then why are you acting like that?”

“How am I acting?”

“You are obviously behaving like you are sulking.”

“What an unpleasant... speculation,” defied Javier.

“More like an accurate speculation,” quipped Lloyd.

“It is the wrong one.”

“Is it?”

Lloyd then grinned and glued to Javier as they stepped out of the building. He then stared hard at Javier with a meaningful side glance.

“It’s because of the lullaby, isn’t it?” postulated Lloyd.

“...”

Javier stopped dead and turned to Lloyd. Could it be that Lloyd hit home? Javier finally spoke up.

“The lullaby service. I did not know it was given free of charge.”

“Hmm?”

“I had to teach you the Asrahan Core Technique to hear your lullaby.”

“Aha.” Lloyd’s smile deepened. “And that is why you’re upset?”

“I am not upset as I told you before.”

“But,” pointed out Lloyd, “the Asrahan Core Technique was the result of a collaborative effort between you and I. Weren’t you struggling by yourself because you missed the most vital aspect of the skill?” asked Lloyd.

“But-”

“Don’t worry,” interrupted Lloyd. “It’s not free. Do you peg me as someone who bestows kindness to people for free?”

“No, never.”

“Right?”

“Yes,” agreed Javier, “For Master Lloyd is a petty cheat who likes to hold long grudges against people and cannot even fathom doing good and philanthropic deeds.”

“You know, you strangely become very detailed in moments like these,” said Lloyd.

“I was simply stating the truth here.”

“Hmm, hmm. Anyway, my lullaby service is not free. You can stay rest assured. I’m going to make sure that she pays for my lullaby service.”

“Is that so?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, yes.”

“I knew it,” scoffed Javier.

“...”

Why is he scoffing? And what’s that shrug in relief? Lloyd flashed a wry smile. Whatever the case was, the sultan’s daughter was now gone, and it was time to do business.

“Do you plan on looking around the construction area right away?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, since I should get a feel for the atmosphere before anything,” answered Lloyd.

“By that, you mean-”

“I need to see what it’s like here.”

Lloyd strode dutifully as he answered Javier's question, heading to the city district quite distant from his lodging. The scenery of the deserted small city spanned in front of him. Under the sweltering sun of the desert, the sandy wind blew restlessly. Lloyd then spotted a line of people in the windy plaza. They were those who had lined up to receive the ration Lloyd carried from Ahinsya.

"They must have been hungry."

Javier spoke as he frowned. Indeed, everyone didn't look good. Most of them were scrawny, and their skins were dry and rough.

"After all, they had to endure a prolonged drought," replied Lloyd with astonishment in his voice. "Lack of water. Lack of crops. This place is lucky because it's fertile, at least. Otherwise, everyone would have starved to death already."

It was true. Lloyd was hit with the story in the novel. The city of Kandara was one of the places Javier passed through. And almost all its people perished after several years of drought until the city disappeared at last.

But the sultan does nothing about it. He didn't even give out relief supplies. Worse, he forbade people from moving elsewhere to contain the public rage until everyone died trapped there.

And that became the seed of revolt. The resentment and rage against the sultan and the flame of hatred burned to the sky until the people succeeded in bringing down the sultan from his throne. In short, this city represented the trigger of revolt and civil war in the novel.

"Anyway, thank goodness that we had the Padashar from the sultan," remarked Lloyd. "Did you know that, technically, the food was gifted to us by the great and omnipotent sultan?"

"Wait, are you taking credit when it was the sultan that spent the money?" accused Javier with a gaze.

"Well, yeah, you're right," admitted Lloyd.

Lloyd then shrugged as he wistfully looked at the people receiving the food from the delegation.

“You know, it doesn’t look like they’re so happy to see us even though we brought them food.”

“Yes, it appears so.”

The thing was, people were throwing glances from time to time at the delegation and Lloyd and Javier. But they weren’t so nice. They were full of alarm. Some didn’t even hide their cynical and subtle hostility toward them. But Lloyd wasn’t offended by their behavior. He knew why they were acting like that.

It’s because I’m here under the sultan’s order.

Lloyd signed the contract with the sultan to construct something here. He came to this place at the sultan’s command with the sultan’s guards and people. The whole delegation was flashy, to say the least. As such, it was only obvious how he would be viewed by the residents here.

The sultan’s stool pigeon. Spiteful informant. We’re nothing more than that in their eyes.

The bitter smile on Lloyd’s face deepened. This place was suffering from several years of drought, but Ahinsya stood in stark contrast with Kandara due to its prosperity. Ahinsya enjoyed perpetual abundance. Drought was irrelevant there. This reason was simple. The sultan was in Ahinsya.

The sultan spends an exorbitant amount of money all the time. He hires magicians and buys thousands of carriages and ships with his enormous capital to transfer water to Ahinsya through various channels.

And so, Ahinsya never ran out of water. But what happened to the regions that didn’t receive the grace of the sultan? They had to go through all sorts of hardships when the drought struck. The land dried and cracked, and the crops desiccated. But no one could leave this cruel, arid land and dream of moving into the prosperous Ahinsya due to their prosperity.

This sultan kingdom strictly classifies people through their class. People are classified by region. Those living in Ahinsya are the top brass of the kingdom. And those that come next are the ones living around the capital. The lowest in the pyramid system are the ones living in the provinces.

The closer they lived to Ahinsya, the higher their status was. What about those in the lower class? They were permitted to reside in regions that suited their social class. In short, anybody who was born in the lower brass of society could never set foot in Ahinsya ever.

It's dirty. Unfair. And it's not like one can climb the social ladder so easily. The chances of winning the lottery are higher.

In other words, those in the lower class of the sultan kingdom suffered through the drought for their entire lives.

That's why several regions in the kingdom are antagonistic.

The thing is, if everybody's stomach was satisfied, none of this class system would have mattered. That was the case for the past 200 years. But as the drought frequently plagued the regions in recent years, everyone started to flip their lids. The atmosphere was the same in the Kandahar region and Kandara, the central city of the region. The sultan was already their enemy. It was just that they didn't have the power to voice out themselves. As such, Lloyd and the others wouldn't be welcomed as they came under the order of the sultan, even if he showered them with food.

Duh. People here are not foolish. What good does an occasional supply of food do to them when the sultan forever locks them up in agony? They'll never be grateful for the sultan. Instead, they probably feel like they're being managed like livestock. I mean, I'd feel the same way.

As his thinking developed that way, Lloyd was able to understand their antagonistic gaze well enough. But at the same time, he couldn't help but feel frustrated.

"Haa. I still need their cooperation."

“What?”

Lloyd was talking to himself, speaking his thoughts aloud. But it looked like Javier heard it. He cocked his head in confusion. Lloyd scoffed before shrugging and speaking.

“No, never mind. I think I understand what’s going on. Let’s get moving.”

Lloyd then guided Javier into an unpopulated area, and he brought Ggoming out.

“Ggoming,” called Lloyd.

“Ggoming!”

“I think you need to carry us and move around. We’ll be heavy, but can you do it?”

“Ggomiming!”

“Yes, thank you.”

Ggoming nodded as though it was A-OK. Lloyd stroked his round head and asked the others in his embrace.

“Are you guys feeling hot down there?”

“Ppodong!”

“Bangul!”

“Hamang!”

“Not bored or hungry?”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha!”

The fantastical creatures heartily answered that they were okay. Lloyd was grateful and proud of them.

“Yes, good. Then let’s get started.”

Lloyd fed the red sunflower seed to Ggoming and carried him and Javier on his back. Ggoming flew up as he spread out his wings.

“To the west!”

“Ggoming!”

In no time, they were high up in the air and outside Kandara. Ggoming flew in the direction of the west, passing countless dunes under him. Lloyd activated his surveying skill, Subterranean Scanning.

Let’s see.

His gaze swept over the underground, 16 feet deep. It scanned thoroughly lest he missed an area. But nothing he wanted could be spotted.

“It’s not here. Could it be somewhere deeper than 16 feet?”

“What...?”

“No, never mind.”

“...”

Nothing? Javier asked himself. Then why was Master Lloyd looking dismayed? Javier was curious as he stayed on Ggoming’s back.

He must be looking around the areas where the construction will take place. Surveying. Did he call it? But Master Lloyd is slightly different from his usual self.

This time, there was a slight difference in the manner Master Lloyd surveyed the ground. It looked like he had a specific target he wanted to uncover but couldn’t.

What could he be looking for?

Javier was curious, but before his curiosity could be resolved, the scenery under him changed. Ggoming, who faithfully flew toward the west, was no longer flying over the desert. Intermittent patches of grass appeared in their view until the foot of a mountain appeared. Then the streams of water flowing down from the mountain came into view.

“Higher,” Lloyd said calmly.

“Ggoming!”

Ggoming fluttered his wings, taking them higher to the foot of the mountain. The wind gradually turned chiller, colder. At last, a white permanent snow line spanned below them. Lloyd asked Ggoming to land on the field of snow. And he looked around.

“Hmm... Good. No contaminants. No bacteria. Just the right amount of sodium. Just perfect.”

Satisfaction appeared in Lloyd’s eyes. This was the place where the water that would be used for the Qanat was produced. The permanent snow line would melt to form a waterway that would flow along the foot of the mountain. Then he could construct the intake station along the waterway, and the water gathered that way would be transferred via the underground channel.

“So, Hamang,” called Lloyd.

“Hamang!”

“Time to work today.”

“Hamamang!”

Lloyd brought Hamang out of his pocket. And pointing at the snow field, he gently asked, “Tell me, do you like ice snacks?”

“Hamang!”

“So, anything with water is good for you, yeah? Then what about that?”

“Hamamang!”

Hamang nodded his head, saying that it went without saying that he liked it. A content smile appeared on Lloyd’s mouth.

“All right. I want you to put as much as you can of that in your mouth and turn it all into water. Do you remember the Kandara city we just visited? The people there are very thirsty,” explained Lloyd.

“Hamang!”

From then on, Hamang darted in the direction of the snowfield as though he was back home. Then he took a bite of the white snow, swallowed it, and the snow melted to fill his stomach. Hamang became happier with it.

“Hamamang! Hamang! Hamamamang!”

He continued to devour the snow, and his stomach swayed up and down, inflating his size in no time. Soon, he grew to become 229 feet in diameter.

“Are you happy now that your stomach is all full?” asked Lloyd.

“Humu-mung! Humung!”

Hamang responded, saying that he couldn’t be any happier. A smile appeared on Lloyd’s face as well.

“Great. Then let’s go back.”

“Humung!”

Everyone flew up again toward the east on Ggoming’s back. Hamang, on the other hand, rolled and rolled, coming down the foot of the mountain and traversing the desert. And when they were finally back in Kandara, it was already deep into the night.

“What now, Master Lloyd?” asked Javier. “You seemed to have instructed Sir Hamang to carry the water and give it to the people.”

“You’re right,” Lloyd agreed, “I came to give it to them.”

“Then do you plan on waiting until morning arrives?”

“Hm? Why?”

“Because everyone should be sleeping now-”

“That’s why we must wake them up.”

“Excuse me?”

Javier thought he heard him wrong. Lloyd smiled.

“You saw when we got to the foot of the mountain where the intake station will be constructed, right? How distant it is from here.”

“Yes.”

“It was almost 25 miles away.”

“Indeed.”

“So...” Lloyd paused before continuing. “The distance is too far, so we can’t do this job on our own. People here must help us. So we’ve got to wake them all up and give water,” he said matter-of-factly.

“But,” protested Javier, “an act of generosity and charity must be-”

“Must be done so openly and obviously. Yes, yes, of course.” Lloyd then put on an evil and rewarding smile before he finally said, “That’s how we can earn brownie points from them, right?”

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Chapter 190: A Greedy Man’s Charity (3)

“That’s how we can earn brownie points from them, right?”

Lloyd’s smile looked evil and happy. Sly and proud. So, Javier thought to himself...

This man is serious.

Lloyd Frontera. The young master he served. The former hooligan, the dreadfully hateful figure. How in the world did he come up with these ideas? How in the world did he behave like this without a second of hesitation? Javier was genuinely curious. Entranced by the existence of human beings, he lifted his head and stared at everyone gathered in the plaza in the middle of the night. They were the people of Kandara.

“Okay! Line up! Line up here! Don’t forget to bring a bucket or basin with you!”

A long line of people extended in front of Lloyd, and he loudly yelled at them, leading the groggy, half-asleep, and yawning individuals into a line. He quickly guided those glancing around in wonder. Afterward, Lloyd distributed water in the order they were in.

“So, Hamang,” called Lloyd.

“Humung!” said Hamang, keeping his mouth tight shut lest water spilled out of it.

“You know what to do, right? Spit out a little at a time so it doesn’t overflow.”

“Humu-mung! The 36-foot giant water balloon, no, Hamang responded and obeyed Lloyd’s instruction.

“One bucket!”

“Humung!”

Splash! Hamang spat water out through the straw in his mouth. The water came from melting the permanent snow at the peak of a mountain range dozens of miles away. The top-quality, pure, and pristine water started filling the bucket in no time. Lloyd’s white teeth were exposed as he grinned wide.

“Now, may you have a mighty day with this!” encouraged Lloyd.

“Oh? Okay...”

A citizen wearing a confused look walked off, lugging the bucket away. But he continued to look back as if he couldn’t shake off the dismay in him. He gave a look at Lloyd, who was smiling nonchalantly. And then, he looked at Hamang, who was as big as a mountain. He finally stared at the clean water splashing in his bucket. What kind of luck is this? The man wondered as he cocked his head. Carrying the water that would last more than a day, he trudged back home. Most of the citizens had a similar reaction. Meanwhile, a big and prideful smile appeared on Lloyd’s mouth.

Good. This is really good. This is how we do charity. By making it completely public!

It was really the case. He needed to make it blatant. Doing the opposite would only bring trouble.

Anonymous charity? Then people really won’t know of it.

One can volunteer his butt off, sure. But what’s the point if nobody knows it? There’s no reward if no one knows of one’s good works. That was something Lloyd desperately wanted to avoid.

After all, I’m no hero.

There were many respectable, great men and women in this world, particularly those who did good deeds behind everyone’s back. They didn’t receive any rewards or anything similar. They were willing to work and

suffer without any recognition. Making someone happy through their act of goodness. That alone was the goal of their sincere charity, and those types of people were thick on the ground in the world. However, Lloyd? He was different.

I'm not that kind of a person. I'm just not cut out for it.

He was different. He wasn't that amazing and didn't dare wish for it. Moreover, unlike such women and men of exemplary character, Lloyd clearly wanted something in return. In other words, his kindness came with strings attached.

I'm doing all of this hoping I'd get something. Like, for example, the people's cooperation.

Lloyd looked at the people receiving the water, and he could see that they were swelled with surprise and dismay. Even still, their gaze remained cold. There remained the same sense of alarm. A doubt of sorts that ascertained this man wanted something in return. Such a distrustful sentiment seemed to linger in their gaze. And so...

I have to change that perception. Break down their walls and make them like me. That's the core of the construction project.

Qanat. The facility he had boasted to the sultan to build. But the process to create one was not simple.

The distance is too far.

Lloyd made a recollection of the mountain range he had gone to in the afternoon. The distance reached over 22 miles. That distance in South Korea was equivalent to the travel between Seoul Station and Munsan county in Paju city. From the center of Seoul to the areas near the Military Demarcation Line. Make that horizontal, and the 22 miles would cover the far corner of Gangdong-gu to the Gangseo-gu beyond the Gimpo international airport. Southward, one can reach Suwon from Seoul station. In short, it was a tremendous distance.

That's why I can't just go and start constructing. That would take me more than a year to finish everything.

And even that was only if Bangul, the high-functioning excavating machine, and Javier were utilized for the project. But it was not what Lloyd wanted.

Nope. Nuh-uh. That can't happen. I'm not going to rot here for an entire year! Not a chance.

What was more, this place wasn't his fiefdom. Building up someone else's neighborhood to open up a negotiation with the sultan wasn't enough of a reward for Lloyd to waste a year of his precious life here.

The novel said that there are many caves here and there beneath.

Lloyd recalled the story in the novel. It mentioned that the Kandahar region held caves under the ground woven so intricately. It wasn't a natural one. About 1,000 years ago, the monks who came to hide in this region away from religious oppression dug the caves, their work lasting more than 100 years. And so, three generations of monks lived as recluses, shunned away from the sun.

So, the caves are said to have remained to this day. Thanks to that, the protesters against the sultan used it as their hideout.

Lloyd planned on using the caves because it would be much more convenient for him to connect the existing caves than to dig fresh ones in the ground.

I won't be able to connect them in a straight line. But finding the most efficient route will be enough. A route that ensures the shortest travel time even if the caves are divided into dozens of independent paths. A route that ensures the least excavation distance and that will direct the water without any spillages or leaks.

Lloyd just had to find them. Only after then could he start surveying and designing. Moreover, there was one more advantage to utilizing the existing

cave beside the reduced construction period and effort.

Since the caves are dug underground, they are naturally waterproof. In other words, it's set up so the water won't leak into the ground.

The crux of the Qanat project was making sure that the underground water did not seep into the earth. That way, the water drawn from the mountain range would not be contaminated. So, using the cave that was already waterproof would give him one less issue to think about. And the work and time necessary for the construction would be reduced just as much.

That's why I kept observing the ground as I surveyed. But...

Lloyd couldn't find anything. He used his Subterranean Scanning option until his eyes grew bloodshot but failed. What it meant was clear.

It means that the caves the monks dug are located much lower than 16 feet underground.

His Subterranean Scanning skill came with a limit. He could only look up to 16 feet underground. Any further down was impossible.

And it's not like I can dig all day looking for it.

That was too inefficient. It was so even if there were multiple caves. And even if he came across one cave out of luck, he would have to search for dozens more scattered throughout the ground.

I might as well spend a year making a new cave than resort to that.

It was too inefficient. And it wasn't something he wanted for himself either.

So, I'm only left with this option.

Lloyd made a decision. The residents had to lower their guards. He had to be favored and earn their trust. Since these people were the locals of this city and since some among them were already planning a coup, Lloyd could inquire about the locations of the caves all spread out in various places as long as he could earn their trust. With such a goal in mind, Lloyd knuckled

down loudly advertising his kind acts. Once the water distribution was finished, Lloyd called for Ppodong.

“Okay, from here to here. Dig it for me,” Lloyd instructed.

“Ppodong!”

Swish! Swish! Swish! Ppodong dug a square in the ground and thoroughly laid down the flat stones like tiles. Then Lloyd poured the rest of the water there.

“Hamang? You know what to do.”

“Humu-mung!” *Blergh!* Hamang spat out the rest of the water, and it soon filled up the hole Ppodong and Lloyd worked on a moment ago. It was a temporary water storage reservoir.

“Okay, time to build the awning so the water doesn’t evaporate in the afternoon.”

Lloyd put up the pillars around the station and covered them with a large cloth, constructing a temporary awning that would shun the water from the scorching sun.

“Whew.”

Once it was over, the morning sun was rising. But Lloyd didn’t stop there.

“What is that?”

“A sign.”

Lloyd grinned at Javier’s question and stuck the sign in front of the reservoir. The following words were written on the sign.

[This temporary storage reservoir has been constructed by Lloyd Frontera for the people of the city of Kandara. The water is to be used by anyone for free. Moving forward, more water will be drawn every night and stored in here.]

“...”

Javier’s eyes continued to move as he read the writing. Then he noticed additional sentences that were written in smaller fonts.

[Lloyd Frontera treads the path of suffering and tribulation to the distant mountain range for clean water, skipping sleep every night. Only for the people of Kandara! His feet are swollen! His body is fatigued! Fever and chills assail him! The burden placed on him may try to knock him cold, but he doesn't want a thing in return. He does this solely with your happiness and well-being in mind. With an angelic heart, Lloyd Frontera takes another step to bring water to you all today.]

“...”

Angelic heart? He is fatigued? Javier stared hard at Lloyd, who scoffed visibly.

“What? Why? What?”

“...”

“Why are you squinting your eyes like that?” Lloyd demanded to know.

“I think you are too shameless, Master Lloyd.”

“Me? Shameless?”

“Yes.”

“How?” huffed Lloyd.

“In all honesty, Master Lloyd, weren’t you able to draw the water without lifting a finger?”

“What are you saying?”

“The truth. Sir Hamang enthusiastically drank up the water and rolled over here.”

“...”

“Whereas you, Master Lloyd, comfortably sat on Sir Ggoming’s back while he flew around.”

“Ahem...! Hmm! Hmm! That’s what marketing is,” said Lloyd, forcing his voice.

“Marketing?”

“Indeed. That’s exactly right.”

Lloyd flashed a smile that was likened to the one unconscientious employers usually wear.

“A marketing to draw a beautiful result. It’s like a wrapper. Do you think people care about the truth? Never. They only care about the clean water they can enjoy. Who do you think is concerned with where I got the water and how?”

“You mean,” said Javier, “to say that you are willing to exaggerate and lie to draw the result of your desire.”

“But it’s not like I’m cheating anyone in the distribution process, right?”

It was true. The water was pristine. He just slightly exaggerated the process of drawing that very water. Nothing more. The water was the cleanest, finest water melted from the permanent snow line in the mountain peak. It would become a precious source of life for everyone suffering from the drought.

“You know it, too, right? There are many shameless employers who mess with their workers’ livelihoods. Compared to them, I’m an angel. I didn’t lie about where the water came from. I didn’t add any extra ingredients. Moreover, it’s free. Ha! It’ll be hard to find anyone as generous as me out there. Don’t you think so?” insisted Lloyd.

“...”

Javier clamped his mouth shut. What Lloyd was saying was all true and correct, but since they were coming out of Lloyd's mouth, Javier hated him more for it. Just like that, Lloyd planted the sign full of exaggeration and lies in front of the storage reservoir. But he didn't stop there.

"All right, let's go."

"What?"

"Don't cock your head. It's time to advertise," said Lloyd.

"..."

Advertise? What? Javier followed Lloyd with a dazed feeling, and the sunny morning street welcomed them. From then on, Javier was able to see Lloyd's true colors.

"My! Hello, sir! How are you?" suddenly greeted Lloyd as he stopped in front of an elderly man.

"Huh? Excuse me?"

"Do you not remember who I am?" Lloyd asked, plastering a big smile on his face and ignoring the confused look of the man, who was just walking down the street.

Evidently flustered, the man replied, "You are, of course-"

"My name is Lloyd Frontera. Do you remember me, sir? Did you not see me yesterday morning?" imposed Lloyd.

"Th-that's-"

"Yes, yes," said Lloyd jovially. "I remember you as well, of course. You were the 23rd person to receive water from me. Let's see, aha! I am right. Night or morning, you look dashing, sir. Tell me, how was the water you received? Did you like it?"

"Uh, yes, of course-"

“Oh, you did!” exclaimed Lloyd, cutting in. “That is a relief! Thank you!”

“Wait, I...”

“The water wasn’t too cold or hot?”

“Of course-”

“Thankfully, the temperature seems to have been perfect as well. My, my, what a relief. Thank you!”

After handshaking the elderly man with both hands, Lloyd bowed like a well-oiled hinge and a smooth folder phone. His torso was curved at an acute angle. Just like that, he greeted the nameless elderly folks one by one while relentlessly stressing the good deeds he did the previous night.

“Have a nice day, sir!”

“O-okay...”

One of the dismayed and troubled elderly men hurried off, but Lloyd didn’t care. He was still unabashed.

I have to be more shameless.

It was all or nothing. He had to definitively show that he was on their side. And so, Lloyd became the friendliest guy in town, much like politicians campaigning before an election. Of course, his good deeds continued. He drew water from the mountain range every night, filling up the temporary water reservoir. In the afternoon, he promoted his kind work as he greeted people around. And when his sacrificial campaigning reached the 15th day, at last, there came the first sign of change in the villagers’ attitudes toward Lloyd.

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Chapter 191: Between Kidnapping and Fishing (1)

"If a vehicle near the top of the retaining wall has an equal distribution load like a building, these loads increase earth’s pressure on the retaining wall. Fixed loads such as buildings convert the weight of the building into the weight of the backfill soil of the retaining wall. And it calculates the earth’s pressure by seeing that there is more soil.”

“H-hold on...”

The sun had fallen, and it was early at night. In a lodging in Kandara, a calm voice echoed under the flickering candlelight. The voice was serious. Consistent. Monotonous. Without a single emotion. There was only an enumeration of knowledge. As the calm and merciless lullaby struck the air, a lady pleaded. Please make it stop. I’m going to collapse. My eyes will close in despair and open up tomorrow morning. But the man who was singing the lullaby was absolutely void of any mercy, tolerance, or kindness in his voice.

"The influence of roads or railways installed near the top of the retaining wall cannot be accurately converted to static loads because they cause a dynamic reaction due to repeated loads. However, in the case of roads, it is common to design with the view that the equal distribution load acts as 1 ton f/m squared for DB-24 and DB-18 loads and 0.7 ton f/m squared for DB-13.5 loads.”

Snore... The resisting lady, Sheherazade, fell asleep. The merciless man, Lloyd, smiled.

“Good.”

The perfect way to put a patient with sword master syndrome to sleep was with a lullaby. Since they had severe insomnia and were constantly sleep-deprived, the lullaby worked like a charm. What was better was that he didn’t have to worry about them developing resistance or side effects.

Rather, it becomes a habit.

What happens when a sleep-deprived individual gets a good night's sleep with one lullaby and the taste of a sweet dream? That experience leaves a powerful mark on the body that it keeps wanting more. Their body yearns more. Sing a lullaby for me! It’s the only thing that can make me get a good night's sleep! Literally speaking, the body yearns for it more than the mind.

And that was proven by Javier even today. Bwhahaha.

Javier was already a sword master, and he could control his senses. But he was somewhat reliant on lullabies to this day.

So that daughter of the sultan won’t be much different.

There was no way that she could resist when Javier couldn’t. She’d flake out until tomorrow morning. Confident of it, Lloyd quietly stepped out of her room and returned to his room with light steps.

“Javier? Have you been waiting for a long time?”

But no response. For some reason, the room was empty. Lloyd shrugged.

“Tsk. Is he out for a walk? He won’t have a chance to sleep if not now.”

Too bad. Javier wouldn’t be able to sleep tonight. Lloyd didn’t intend to wait for Javier to return. He was planning to head to bed right now.

“Whew. I’ve got to get to bed now.”

Lloyd removed his boots and jumped onto the bed. He should try to get some sleep now. That was as he had to wake up at midnight, ride Ggoming, and take Hamang to the western mountain range to draw water. Falling asleep now assured him about three or four hours of rest. As he thought so, just then, the events that happened in the past few days crossed his head. How the residents cast a doubtful and cold glance at Lloyd. How they seemed to accuse him of being the sultan’s stool pigeon and cunning informant. How resentful their gaze was! Lloyd acted more thick-skinned despite everything. He headed to the west to draw water every day. He then

shared it with the resentful villagers, loudly showing that he was sacrificing himself for them.

I'm going to do it tomorrow too. I'll gather everyone around in the morning and distribute water. How many days has it been? 15? It's about time that people start to look at me differently. There have to be some signs now. Maybe I'll see some today?

Lloyd wouldn't know except the fact that what he was doing now was likened to fishing. He simply cast a fishing pole down the water, and it was up to the fish to bite down on the bait. He could only wait for any movements to occur while gazing at the calm water after throwing a juicy bait. So, he had...

Whew...

His vision started to grow dark. His feelings grew dazed. As if he was floating high or sinking into the bed, sleep charged at him, his consciousness taking him to dreamland. Every part of him relaxed. Breathing grew calm. And his neck was tightened.

Grab! "...!"

A grip suddenly grabbed his neck. Lloyd snapped his eyes open and held out his hands by reflex. But he failed because someone pinned them down tight, pressing his whole body, including his arms and legs.

"Argh...! Ergh! Eup!"

Lloyd flailed and struggled as his neck and body were pressed down. He counted several intruders, and he tried hard to get a look at them. The room was dark without any light, and Lloyd could only vaguely make out the outlines of his attackers.

Ten?

No, there were more. Five were pinning him down, and about five or six surrounded him. Lloyd activated the Asrahan Core Technique right away.

Ziiing!

“Ack...?!”

“My strength...”

“Don’t let go of him!”

Lloyd started to absorb the mana of those that touched him. They were assaulted with a pang of dizziness and weakness. Lloyd could hear the fuss and mess they made in dismay. Just then...

Thump! His head burned and his vision was filled with white light. Could it be that Lloyd was hit with a club? The world seemed to spin around him. And the Asrahan Core Technique was deactivated right away. There were frantic voices of men around him.

“Whew... Ha... What was that?”

“Don’t just stand there like a fool. Tie him up. Come on.”

The rustling, squeezing, and tying sound came as Lloyd’s wrists and ankles tightened. Lloyd felt stifled, so he wondered if his blood wasn’t circulating properly. His hands and feet tingled and turned numb. Soon, he sensed a muzzle over his mouth.

“Cover him up with this. We never know when he’ll wake up again.”

They must have put a cover over his head. Everything became dark.

“Okay, come on. Before that silver-haired guard comes back.”

Javier. Where are you? Lloyd lifted his head with a struggle. But he couldn’t see anything through the cover. He again tried the Asrahan Core Technique, but it was only a meaningless fight as his hands and feet were tied up. But Lloyd was able to stay calm. He didn’t even panic or activate the Supercharge optional skill. Instead, he struggled a few times with all his might. But that stopped when the rope started scraping his skin.

“Now, do you understand what predicament you’re in?”

Nod. The question was directed to Lloyd, and he nodded. The speaker seemed to be satisfied by Lloyd’s answer.

“You can resist, but that’s a waste of energy. You catch on quickly. I like that.”

“...”

“Okay, move him.”

Lloyd felt himself being carried by someone big. He didn’t fight. It was meaningless to do so now. As he was carried on someone’s shoulder like a bag of rice, Lloyd concentrated his senses on the surrounding sound and flow of the air.

I knew they’d be heading outside the city.

Footsteps. A dog barking on the street. The direction of the wind and its smell. After a long while, he found himself being placed on a hard floor.

“On your knees.”

Lloyd obeyed the command, and the bag covering his face was finally removed.

“...”

His forehead ached from the blow he received earlier, and he looked up as he grimaced. It was a dark room, and there were about 20 people surrounding him, all of whom Lloyd could only make out their outlines.

Am I in a waste material warehouse?

The room was filled with the smell of rotten wood and the musty smell of dust. There were also a few windows sparsely nailed with planks. The high ceiling supported by the pillar was covered with spider webs.

Woah. This really feels like a place for kidnapping.

Lloyd sighed internally. This one seemed like the scene he used to see in gangster or noir movies. So, he couldn't help but smirk. As soon as the muzzle was removed from his mouth, Lloyd asked a question of the men.

"All of you. Who are you?"

But they all stared back at Lloyd without a word, the heavy silence narrowing on Lloyd like a siege. The answer came very much later.

"Do you not understand the predicament you are in? You seemed to be confused. We ask the questions. You answer."

One of the men stepped forward. Tall with broad shoulders. He had blond hair and a fit physique. He approached Lloyd and got down on one knee to be at eye level. Stroking his rough beard, he icily stared at Lloyd.

"You. Why are you sacrificing yourself for the city?"

The man continued to speak.

"Everyday, you distribute water to the people after drawing it in your eerie monster's belly. Then you boast of it all day. That's why it's strange. We are always thankful for any generosity, but your actions clearly have an ulterior motive. So." The man's gaze grew colder. Shaper. "What is it that you want? Why are you boisterously advertising your charitable actions?"

The man's gaze was likened to a detective interrogating a criminal or a lawyer accusing a witness. It was stern. No, it was dangerous. The same went for everyone standing around him. They appeared to be ready to teach him some violent lessons if Lloyd didn't give the answer they wanted or resisted and obstinately clamped his mouth. And so, Lloyd quickly spoke.

"Oh, I'm glad that you asked me that question."

Lloyd smacked his lips with saliva and knuckled down to talk as though he had been waiting for this moment and the chance to talk. He then went all out.

“I felt very cramped while you brought me here after attacking me when I was about to fall asleep. It was all because of the sudden bag over my head,” said Lloyd, “But I am glad that you are letting me speak now. It looks like you have a lot of questions, so I suppose I should introduce myself first. Nice to meet you. I am Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of Count Arcos Frontera, who is the lord of the Frontera county in the Magentano Kingdom.”

“Oh, it’s nice to meet...”

“To answer your question first, you all doubted my kind actions and wondered what my intentions were. I have to admit that my actions were poles apart from those amazing individuals who choose to cover and hide their good actions instead of flaunting them as I did. That’s why I had been wanting to give an explanation, and I’m glad I have the chance now.”

“Um, well, of course...”

“First, I am not the sultan’s informant or his stool pigeon. You won’t believe me when I say that, of course. So, to understand everything, you must know the history of Frontera county and my family situation. About two years and a few months ago, Frontera county, which was a barony back then, found itself under a crippling debt. The sky seemed to crumble over me, and the ground sank beneath me. I was in despair and abyss. But I could not give up. Just like how everyone goes through hard and unfortunate times in life, I simply lived on thinking that this storm was just another test of life. The thought gave me strength and hope. And so, I made a new offer to the bar owner in the central plaza of my fiefdom.”

“Wait, hold on-”

“So I made the ondol... Blah blah blah... Because I could do it so well, the pavement road... Blah blah... Built the mine with the expectation and enthusiasm of my family and people... And in Cremo, I decided to move forward amid the raving attention being poured on me... Blah blah... Triple mana blast was used with the deep resolution that I cannot retreat when the queen’s life was on the line...”

Lloyd went on. Nonstop. He continued to talk endlessly, and the faces of the men around him changed to that of confusion. This wasn't like anything they expected. This foreigner, Lloyd, was suspected of being the sultan's informant. And that was why they dragged him here. To interrogate what in the world he was doing in this city, and their expectation was that this stool pigeon would be obstinate and shut his mouth without spilling anything. Thus, they came here with a venomous determination that they would not hesitate to be ruthless and cruel. But a frank, tedious, and sickening narration of his life story? That was the last thing they expected to hear. Unable to endure any longer, the blond man shouted.

"S-stop!"

"Excuse me...?" asked Lloyd with a quizzical look on his face.

"Are you insulting us?!"

"No, you had doubts about my intentions, and I was just giving my most honest and elaborate answer."

"But-"

"Anyway, I'm not done yet. You asked. So, please listen. Captain Frontera is just about to make an appearance to exterminate the swarm of locusts."

"..."

"From the moment I grabbed the lid, I burst with a sense of calling I never knew I had. It was coming from deep within. So, I..."

Stop it. Please stop it, you nut-job. The blond-haired man wanted to beg. A look of desperation appeared on everyone's faces, their eyes slowly blanking out while Lloyd went on with his unending and forthright life story. They nodded mechanically as they listened. Meanwhile, Lloyd cast a glance at a window in the corner. In between the planks that covered it, through a gap, Lloyd exchanged his gaze with Javier, who had been on standby.

They took the bait!

The rebels bit the bait. So now, it was time to find and take over the caves they used as their hideouts.

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Chapter 192: Between Kidnapping and Fishing (2)

Is that what you call fishing?

Lloyd's never-ending words. The dumbstruck kidnappers. And Javier lightly frowned as he watched what was happening in the warehouse outside through the window...

Did Master Lloyd really predict this situation would happen?

It appeared so. Then his mind took him back to the event in the afternoon when Lloyd, with an unusually serious look, told him that kidnappers would come that night. So, he was to wait near the room and never take any action until Lloyd was in danger. He was to follow the kidnappers and observe the situation. At Lloyd's request, Javier asked back how on earth he could predict such a thing. Lloyd didn't give an answer. He simply flashed a grin and said that it was a hunch.

"..."

Javier's gaze deepened as he remembered Lloyd's words. Sometimes, no, oftentimes, Javier was entranced by his young master. What was happening now was too accurate to be a hunch. Could it be that he had an amazing intuition? Or was he simply intelligent?

No, this feat is far too large for those explanations.

Javier didn't regard Lloyd as a genius based on his observations. Certainly, his young master was slightly more quick-witted than most others. But there wasn't any streak of ingenious intelligence in him. And so, Javier posited another possibility.

There might be something I don't know.

Looking back, it was always the case. It was the case when Lloyd figured out a way to complete the Asrahan Core Technique, which he himself struggled hard to perfect it. The same case when Lloyd predicted the

assassination of the queen back in the capital. And when he doubted Cannavaro, the warlock in Namaran.

Sometimes... he feels like someone who's seen a glimpse of the future or has already experienced it.

Javier knew very well that such a thing was impossible. But still, Lloyd gave off that feeling. It was as if he borrowed a portion of a memory of an omnipotent being. Along those lines, he manifested an intuition that went beyond one's senses and intelligence. It was the same today.

I should watch over him more.

He couldn't ascertain anything yet. It was just a gut feeling. Javier stared into the inside of the warehouse with a deepened gaze and observed Lloyd, who was wrapping the kidnappers around his little finger with his words. Thankfully, his endless story was nearing its end.

"That's why I did it... I felt a strong sense of duty after recognizing the heavy burden on the shoulders of the people here and started drawing water to follow my heart. That is how I came to distribute water to people here. Haah, but I don't regret it. Even if I could time travel and go back a few days ago and know in advance that I would get kidnapped, I'll make the same choice."

"To earn the trust of the people here and finish the construction and bring the sultan to the negotiation table?"

"Oh, I suppose you understood where I was getting at?"

"Of course," said the man, dumbfounded that Lloyd was surprised. "You've been confessing for an hour and a half."

Lloyd smiled as he looked up. The blond-haired man, who was the leader among the kidnappers, heaved a drawn sigh. He couldn't help it.

What kind of guy is this?

Dismay pervaded the man’s eyes as he looked at Lloyd. At first, he thought this foreigner was working for the sultan to report everything about this place. The construction was just a pretense to look into the inner workings of the region. That was what he thought Lloyd was. As such, the man was bothered as Lloyd continued to be kind and distribute water. His doubts worsened, and it put him on edge. He was dead certain that this man had something up his sleeve. An ulterior motive of some kind. In the end, he decided to kidnap him. Even if he had to threaten and interrogate him, he would uncover the man’s intentions as well as the sultan’s schemes and objectives. But...

“Let me be frank with you. I have never received such a confession like this,” the man said. “I am torn whether I should compliment you for your elaborate story or say you went overboard. Anyway, I think I know what you are now.”

“What am I?” asked Lloyd, intrigued.

“A man who wants to use us.”

The blond-haired man’s eyes grew stern as he stared at Lloyd. “You. I suppose you already know who we are, right?”

“Yes, of course,” said Lloyd without hiding.

“Can you guess who I am?”

“Certainly, I do. You are Termes, the leader of the rebels.”

“I knew it.” Termes scoffed. “All that sharing of water to people. That was to meet us. Am I right?”

“Yes,” admitted Lloyd, “though it took longer than I expected.”

A smile formed on Lloyd’s mouth. Termes was right. Lloyd did wait for the rebels to show up. He strove to meet them, and this was the best way. There was absolutely no way the residents would answer nicely if Lloyd went up to them and asked where and how he could meet the rebels. Threatening the

people wasn’t the answer either. As such, Lloyd resorted to excessive philanthropy for the people here. He went all out, explicitly showing that he was doing something good here. He did the math and figured that the rebels would notice him eventually, that they would grow more doubtful and vigilant against him as they watched him do good deeds every day. And his prediction was spot on.

After all, they thought I was working for the sultan.

It would have looked more strange that a sultan’s man was doing good deeds for the community. Lloyd capitalized on that and used it as bait. And thankfully, he was able to get kidnapped by the rebel and thereby succeeded in meeting them.

“I was expecting that you would come to meet me last night or today. Well, though, your method was much rougher than I predicted,” said Lloyd as he scoffed and frowned. A corner of his forehead was slightly swollen because of the blow. Termes, the leader of the rebel, looked at Lloyd more stringently.

“How bold of you. We could have knocked you out harder.”

“Such a thing,” said Lloyd, “could happen if I was kidnapped by mountain thieves or robbers who have no sense of morality. They scare and kidnap innocent people.”

“Are you trying to criticize us?”

“No. It hurt a while ago, but I can understand well enough.”

“Then what is it that you want from us?”

Termes’s eyes grew suggestive. Actually, he still had doubts about Lloyd. It was so even after Lloyd shared his entire life story in full detail. Why? Such stories could be fabricated well enough. Anyone could easily come up with a similar lie. That was the reason why he didn’t stop Lloyd when he blabbered. As the story drew out, there was a greater chance for loopholes

to be found, and it would be easier for Termes to spot them. But he couldn't find any loopholes or lies in Lloyd's story, and that was surprising.

I must figure out what this man is up to.

If this foreigner was indeed working for the sultan and trying to cleanse the rebels, slashing his neck was the best option.

But I should listen to his story first.

Termes decided to listen first before judging. He waited for Lloyd to speak. Lloyd faintly smiled.

"What do I want? Well, it's simple. Hand over all your hideouts."

"What...?"

Termes thought he heard him wrong. He never imagined that a kidnapped man with tied hands and feet would make such a preposterous demand. But Lloyd went further, and his brazen voice pierced everyone's ears.

"It is just as I said. All of you must be using the caves scattered throughout the regions as your hideouts, but I just can't find them out on my own. So, please share all of them with me," demanded Lloyd.

"What... Are you out of your mind?"

"No, I'm not. You need to give me those caves to solve the drought that constantly plagues your region."

"What?"

Termes, who was about to fly into a rage, stopped. Give up the caves? That's the solution to drought? What gibberish is that?

"Explain..."

"Of course," said Lloyd with a grin. "As I have told you, I came here after signing a contract with the sultan to build a water facility called Qanat. It's

an underground waterway that can connect the mountain range to this place, traveling about 23 miles."

"Then why do you need our caves?" Termes demanded to know.

"Because I plan on connecting the caves to build the waterway," replied Lloyd.

"..."

"I mean it. That's how I can shorten the construction period. It would equally reduce the time people suffer due to drought. Additionally, the sultan won't need to go so far as to wage war against us to turn things around for him, which means your neighbors and friends won't have to be dragged to war, and my hometown, Frontera county, won't wind up in it either. Everyone will be happy. That is, only if you all kindly give up the caves," explained Lloyd.

"..."

Everyone was at a loss for words. They couldn't rashly give an answer or react. The scale of things Lloyd so nonchalantly narrated now was beyond their expectations and common sense. They thought that Lloyd was a nut-job when he demanded the cave. But now that they listened to his rationale, it made sense somehow.

"Whew, hold on. Let's summarize for a second," said Termes as he suppressed dismay. "So, you want to use our hideouts for your project to solve the drought?"

"Yes."

"To connect them together and build the waterway by drawing water from the mountain range?"

"You're perfectly right."

"Ha. But what about us? What's going to happen to us?"

Termes smirked after a pause.

“Since you know about us already,” Termes went on. “I won’t hide it anymore. You are right. We are rebels against the sultan. We are resentful toward the sultan who does nothing even when our lands are getting destroyed by drought and everyone is in pain. We are ready and resolved to use force to let him know of our sufferings and put an end to this agonizing drought by using the wealth of Ahinsya. That is, even if it means staining our hands with blood.”

Temers paused before continuing to talk.

“So you see, we are rebels. Rebels against the sultan. But what? Give you our hideouts? Then everyone can happily escape the drought? Fine. Let us say that things do go on according to your way. Let us say that the waterway is built. That’s something we will gladly welcome as well. The cause of our pain which provoked us will be gone. But what about afterward? What will happen later when we give out the hideouts for your construction? What will happen to us after losing our safe house?”

A faint hostility appeared in Termes’s eyes as they stared at Lloyd. “Do you think we’ll be safe after we lose them? You are not so innocent to believe that the sultan will forgive us for cooperating with the construction project, right?”

“No, of course not.” Lloyd nodded his head. “It’s obvious he won’t. After all, the sultan is the ruler.”

It was true. The fact was obvious Cooperating in the Qanat construction and giving up their hideouts didn’t guarantee the possibility that the sultan would forgive the rebels. There was no chance it would happen. That kind of happy ending only existed in fairy tales. Lloyd ascertained so without a doubt.

He’s a despot in every sense of the word. Him forgiving the people that schemed rebellion just because they cooperated in his project? No way he’d set such precedence. Never.

The world wasn’t that beautiful. There was no guarantee that cooperation would be awarded. It was the case this time too, and that was why...

Termes, you are reacting exactly the same as I predicted.

Lloyd had seen it coming. He expected that Termes would want to demand what would come after giving up their caves. And so, Lloyd had the answer.

“You can all leave here.”

“What...?”

“What can you do? You’re going to get killed by the sultan, so you’ve got to run.”

“Are you... mocking us?”

Grab! Termes held out his hands and grabbed his collar, looking daggers at him, ready to throw a punch. But Lloyd reacted nonchalantly.

“Mocking you? I am serious now.”

“Then what is with your gibberish? Run? Escape here? Do you really think that’s possible?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“You can come live in my fiefdom.”

“...”

“Defect,” said Lloyd. “Safely. I’m going to take you all.”

“Come on.” Termes shot him a look in disbelief. “Are you in your right mind?”

“Of course.”

They had no elsewhere to go. That was the case even if they didn’t give up the caves. In the end, they were destined to fail and die miserably.

That happens in the novel. Termes and the people beside him all fail. They get captured by the sultan’s forces and perish at the guillotine. But that becomes a catalyst for the emirs in the regions to rise up. A second coup breaks out, and the sultan finally comes down from his throne.

That was how the story went in the novel. In short, Termes and his men would perish and die amidst the emerging revolution.

I’m offering you a chance to live and solve the drought as a bonus. Moreover, I would also put the sultan at the negotiation table and prevent my fiefdom from getting sucked into a war.

This road was the path that ensured everyone’s happiness. This plan would leave everyone to smile. Could it be that Termes vaguely got an idea of his intentions? Could it be that Termes realized that handing the caves to Lloyd will solve the drought and open up the possibility for everyone’s happiness?

“How can I trust you?” Termes asked, his eyes burning with more passion. And his grip on Lloyd’s collar tightened. “Are you insulting us? Or have you lost your mind? How do you expect us to believe such an outrageous suggestion?”

“Is it,” asked Lloyd, “that you need proof that you can trust me?”

“Absolutely.” Termes’s eyes burned still. “That outrageous suggestion better have proof. Show me proof that I can trust. Or else, I’m going to slice your neck and bury you in the sand.”

“Well, fine then.”

Lloyd shrugged, still caught in Termes’s grip. The latter was growling in anger, and Lloyd understood where he was coming from. He was still distrusting Lloyd. He still believed that Lloyd’s suggestion could be a trick of the sultan. So in order to make sure that he would take up the offer,

Lloyd needed a foolproof way to earn his trust. Thankfully, Lloyd had one in mind.

“Then let me ask you one thing,” said Lloyd as he lifted his head, fully taking in the fiery glare of his kidnapper. “Are you free to travel 11 nights and 12 days from today?”

“What...?”

“I need you to fly with me somewhere,” said Lloyd.

“Me? With you?”

“Yes.”

“Go fly with you for 12 days?”

“Yeah, and by then, you’ll have complete trust in me.”

“Where?” asked Termes.

Termes’s question was laden with doubt and confidence that such a thing would never happen. And his stare reflected just as much of his doubt. Receiving the distrustful gaze of Termes, Lloyd grinned. He replied so casually that it sounded like he was suggesting they go to a convenience store or bank to enjoy some air conditioning.

“To Magentano Kingdom. Let’s go meet the queen.”

Therefore, this was a terribly easy matter. What proof in the world was more solid than a grant for asylum issued by the queen herself?

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Chapter 193: Between Kidnapping and Fishing (3)

“Your Majesty, Lloyd Frontera of the delegation and the others have arrived.”

“Let them in.”

Magentano palace. A dignified voice rang aloud through the training hall that sat at the center of the flashy palace. Its door opened.

“...”

Termes, the leader of the rebels in the sultan kingdom, was swallowed by reflex. He couldn’t think straight and was dazed. The door that just opened in front of him. The spectacle of the vast training hall. The red-haired woman standing at the center. Everything felt too unreal. Dazed, he followed Lloyd and got down on his one knee before the woman, and that, too, felt exceedingly unreal.

“Lloyd Frontera, the son of Arcos Frontera, is honored to be in your presence, Your Majesty.”

“D-Damieta Termes of the sultan kingdom is honored to be in the presence of the queen of the Magentano kingdom.”

Fearing he would stutter or give an improper greeting, Termes had practiced dozens of times to himself after he arrived at the palace. He was on pins and needles about making a mistake. But when the moment finally came, his lips automatically moved to greet the queen, and he couldn’t inspect whether he had said it right or stuttered. Breathing heavily, he tried to calm himself. Just then, he thought about the events of the previous days.

I never imagined I would really come here.

About five nights ago, he and his team kidnapped and interrogated Lloyd Frontera because they believed him to be working for the sultan. They did

so because they wanted to discover his ulterior motive behind his good actions toward the people of Kandara and what the sultan was up to.

But getting such an outrageous suggestion was the last thing on my mind.

Lloyd Frontera. He was ballsy enough to throw a suggestion at his kidnappers as though he had been waiting for the right time. His demand was to hand over the caves used for their hideouts. That way, the underground waterway could be constructed to solve the drought. Should they accept that, Lloyd promised to accept them into his fiefdom. The suggestion itself was absolutely outrageous and unimaginable. Termes obviously scoffed at first.

I couldn't trust him.

There was no proof that Lloyd wasn't the sultan's stool pigeon. Thus, he didn't trust Lloyd, arguing that he could never trust the suggestion and that Lloyd must prove he wasn't lying first. Termes roughly and forcefully argued with him, but Lloyd's response was a masterpiece.

He suggested that we should go meet Queen Magentano to receive a grant for asylum.

His suggestion was clearly off the wall. Termes and his team all agreed on that. However, what did Lloyd say in reply?

"Well, you chumps can stay knightly together in this city as you suffer through the drought then."

Lloyd scoffed as he pathetically stared at them. It was because of that stare. That stare reminded Termes of the drought that swept over his hometown and of his young boy, panting helplessly as he perished in his arms. How utterly helpless he was amid such misery! The rancor and despair of that day were brought back to ache his hurt once more.

"Fine... We will go together and see. But you are a dead man if I detect any falsehood in your offer."

He had accepted the offer as he glowered at Lloyd as though he was going to chomp him up. And just like that, they set out on the journey. Termes wasn't worried about getting beaten up. Why? He was confident with his sword. And so, they got on a huge bird and started to fly west. Along the journey, Termes started to go through a change of heart. He was still skeptical in the desert. But when they reached the mountain range, he was curious. And when they crossed into the Magentano border, he was surprised. And today, he was flabbergasted, primarily because he was meeting the queen.

"You are the rebel leader of the sultan kingdom who came with Lloyd Frontera."

Flinch! A soft voice jostled Termes out of his trance. He flinched visibly by reflex.

"Yes, Your Majesty! Yes! I am him, Your Majesty!"

Termes found himself bawling at the top of his lungs. A wry smile formed on her face.

"It is all good. I do not intend on hurting you, so you can relax."

I am not going to hurt you. Her voice was soft but resolute, making it more reliable. The tensions that were built up around Termes's shoulders loosened up at last, and he dared lift his head slightly, stealing a glance at the queen.

That woman is the queen...

Alicia Termina Magentano. The monarch of the Magentano kingdom and the sword master. Termes heard countless rumors about her, how she rose to the level of a sword master at a relatively young age. How she overcame heaps of political conspiracies and strife until she grabbed the queen title. She was said to be an intelligent sword master, and not enough with that, her political skills were known to be top-notch.

But I never pegged her to look like that.

Termes had imagined that he would find himself in the presence of an authoritative figure sitting on a luxurious throne. But in actuality, he wasn't. Queen Magentano was covered with mud. Her modest training clothes, as well as the boots and knee protectors, were all stained with sand and mud. And her top was no different. Though it wasn't muddy, it was soaked in sweat. The shirt that was supposed to be brown was so soaked that it looked black. The towel around her neck was the same. And the long sword in her hand, particularly the hilt, was worn out and tattered due to prolonged use. Every aspect of her appearance made more sense if she was a knight who had just finished her training. The place Termes was met with was the same.

I presume she was training until now.

Behind the queen, a group of knights was scattered, lying on the sandy ground, each clutching their arms, legs, and shoulders in pain. There seemed to be around 50 soldiers, and Termes figured that the queen had beaten them.

Amazing. I see that's the power of a sword master.

The knights in the palace had to be fairly skilled. So, the queen was the monstrous one for being able to beat the daylights out of these 50 knights with only one sword. And now, Termes was here. To meet that monster and get her approval for asylum here.

Is this really happening?

Termes collected his breath again, and everything that was happening around him seemed so unreal. Queen Magentano let out a soft scoff at Termes.

"How surprising."

Her eyes moved toward Lloyd, who was kneeling beside Termes.

"Lloyd Frontera, it has been a long time," Queen Magentano said.

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty. Words fail to capture the joy I am experiencing to be in Your Majesty’s presence,” said Lloyd.

“Truly?”

“Without a doubt, Your Majesty...” said Lloyd after a second of pause. “That is the reason behind my visit here. To have a countenance with Your Majesty while I was in the far sultan kingdom.”

“Tsk. How dare you use such obvious flattery against me. If you followed my orders, you should be residing in Ahinsya right now. How do you explain your presence here?” asked the queen.

“Shall I keep my report short, Your Majesty?”

“I want the details.”

“Your words are my command.”

Lloyd bowed hard, beginning to narrate his long story, keeping as many details as possible. One by one, Lloyd reported the events that took place. By the time he was done, there was a slight crease on her forehead.

“In short... the sultan's kingdom poorly treated my delegation so you signed a contract with the sultan in exchange for starting the negotiation table. And thus, now require the cooperation of this rebel leader to make the construction a success?” summarized the queen.

“Yes, that is indeed right, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“So, you wish that I grant him asylum to my kingdom?”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“Your gratitude comes too early,” pointed out the queen. “I did not grant your request yet.”

“However, I, Lloyd Frontera, have no inkling of doubt on Your Majesty’s mercy and grace.”

“Tsk. I wonder how long your shamelessness will last,” quipped the queen.

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“Enough with your overwhelming gratitude.”

Queen Magentano spoke, but a scoff escaped her at last. She tried to hold it, but it just came out. Lloyd Frontera. She couldn't help but laugh at his absurd behavior.

Yes. The best way to prove that he is not working for the sultan is to come to me when he needs this man’s cooperation.

Taking the rebel leader to this kingdom? That was a bold idea that anybody could come up with. However, what was truly surprising about Lloyd was his outrageous level of initiative to make that bold idea into reality.

Should I say he’s shameless or fearless?

A wry smile slightly deepened as she was torn on which word described Lloyd best. Or could it be that he was the type of person to use any means possible to achieve his goals?

“Lloyd Frontera.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“You are truly an impudent loyal subject.”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“No, no need for forgiveness. If I take a step back, I see your work today will be one of the actions you have taken to fulfill the mission entrusted to you by me.”

“I am overwhelmed with your gratitude for understanding me, Your Majesty.”

“Tsk. Do stop with your gratitude. I know they are empty words,” she said. “So, I should only permit his asylum then?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd bowed, flatter this time. The queen called for her official, and as she spoke aloud the content of the paper, the official wrote it down. Five minutes later, the paper that contained the official insignia of the monarch was in Termes’s hands.

“Now... With this, you and your followers will earn the right to become the people of Magentano,” she announced.

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty,” Termes said. Then he took the paper, his heart beating very fast. Five days ago, this moment was regarded as nothing but Lloyd’s bravado at the remote storage.

I can’t believe his words were real.

Termes felt like he was dreaming. He felt the same even later when he left as he paid his respects to Queen Magentano and when she stopped and called Lloyd.

“Oh, Lloyd Frontera... I have something to tell you now that you are here,” said the queen.

“What could it be, Your Majesty?”

“It is about that warlock you captured in Namaran. Cannavaro.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“The interrogation is expected to end soon,” she went on. “I might need your assistance and summon you to the capital.”

“Me, Your Majesty...?” said Lloyd, his voice growing smaller.

“Indeed. Do you not like me summoning you?”

“Not at all, Your Majesty.”

“That’s what I thought.”

“Of course, Your Majesty.”

“Right. You should be. I can tell just from this unexpected visit from you today. To you, I am someone you wish to meet at any time. Aren’t I correct?”

“T-truly, Your Majesty.”

“Hmm... I think your eyes wavered just now.”

“Your Majesty, that is due to fatigue.”

“Because you flew day and night to meet me?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“That means you will fly day and night like today the next time I call you, correct?”

“Of course... Your Majesty.”

“Again. There. Your eyes wavered.”

“Clearly, it is due to fatigue, Your Majesty.”

“I see. Clearly, it is from fatigue.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Indeed. It must be. I pray you aren’t a selfish and sly man who only comes to meet me when you need me. Isn’t that right?”

Queen Magentano smiled, and her eyes seemed to hold a grudge. Lloyd then left her presence, smiling and sweating.

“Woah.”

Once he was safely out of the training hall, Lloyd heaved out a breath he had been holding back there. Then he turned toward Termes.

“So what now?” asked Lloyd. “Can you trust me now?”

“...”

Termes didn’t say anything. He simply moved his gaze down to his hand holding the paper, which contained the queen’s insignia granting his asylum. Laughter escaped him.

“Ha. I never imagined this to work,” confessed Termes.

“You didn’t, huh?”

“Haah. Not a chance. Truly.”

“So, are you going to take up the suggestion I made?” asked Lloyd.

“Of course. Our caves are yours.”

Termes nodded. Now, there was no reason to not believe this eccentric young master. Should someone in the group still distrust him, Termes was ready to badger them around until they were persuaded.

“Are we then going back to Kandara?” asked Termes.

“Yes, we should. Just as I told you when we took off.”

“11 nights and 12 days. Is that correct?”

“Yeah. But a day shorter if the weather is nice like this.”

“I see,” said Termes.

“Yes, indeed.”

The two walked out of the palace. Just then, Lloyd scoffed.

“Wait a minute,” he added as an afterthought, “we never officially introduced ourselves to each other.”

“Hmm?”

“Let me officially introduce myself. I am Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera county that is loyal to the Magentano family.”

“...”

Lloyd held out his hand, and Termes took it and shook.

“I am Damieta Termes, soon to defect to Frontera county. Nice to meet you.”

“All right,” Lloyd said, “then let’s forget that the kidnapping ever happened.”

“Certainly. You will be the ruler of my future home anyhow.”

“Then I suppose you will no longer club me in the forehead in the middle of the night?”

“I am very sorry about that...”

The leader of the rebel, Termes, broke into an embarrassed smile. 15 days later, thanks to Ggoming’s eager flight, Lloyd and Termes were able to get back to Kandara. But this time, it was to end this prolonged drought. Backed by the active cooperation of the rebels, the time had come for Lloyd to knuckle down and seriously start surveying to build the Qanat.

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Chapter 194: Drillers (1)

The surveying began in full swing. It was a necessary step in every construction project. The process felt repetitive each time but was never the same. This time was no different.

This time, we're connecting the underground tunnels dispersed irregularly all over the place.

The location. Length. Depth. Direction. All these tunnels had different routes and expanded from Kandara to the barren plain of the mountain range in a random fashion. Moreover, each went as deep as 16 feet. So, Subterranean Scanning wasn't enough to identify the shape and size of the tunnels in the ground.

"That is why I need your cooperation, everyone."

Lloyd was at the abandoned warehouse located in the remote part of the city. This was also the place Lloyd was abducted about 15 days ago. Gathered in this nostalgic venue, Lloyd lifted his head and looked around at the people.

"Did you bring the map I mentioned earlier?" asked Lloyd.

Termes and the rebel executives nodded at Lloyd's question. Termes then piled the dozens of maps collected from the others on the table.

"Here you go," he said as he spread out the maps one after another. "These maps," he went on, "indicate most of the tunnels we have acquired or are aware of. Here, we tried grouping them together."

"Grouping them? How?" asked Lloyd.

"They were organized by their proximity to Kandara. If the distance was the same, the tunnels were organized by size. We grouped them based on those two criteria," explained Termes.

“Oh, wow.”

Lloyd yelled in delight in his head. He liked how Termes, the leader of the rebels, was smarter than he expected him to be.

“Great.”

Lloyd’s eyes held a glint of satisfaction as he looked at the maps, which were more detailed than he initially thought. What was more, it looked like the maps had been systematically organized. The markings, units, and symbols were all neatly put together.

Good. Very good.

Their efforts lessened his workload since he wouldn’t have to strain over the backbreaking task of organizing the map and putting together its key.

“I guess my turn has come.”

Crack! Crack!

Lloyd stepped back from the table after taking the maps and stretched his whole body. Termes looked at Lloyd with a confused gaze.

“Your turn?” asked Termes for clarification.

“Oh.” A grin appeared on Lloyd’s face. And in a nonchalant manner, he added, “I’m going to run around for a bit using your maps.”

“Wait, run inside the tunnels?” asked Termes again in disbelief.

“Yes.”

“…”

“This shouldn’t come as a surprise. I need to survey and see everything with my own eyes.”

“The distance will be considerable,” pointed out Termes.

“Exactly the reason why I wore comfortable clothes.”

Indeed, Lloyd was wearing a comfy shirt and wide-fit pants. He even had a towel around his neck. The look was likened to a marathon runner.

“Thanks to your organized maps, though,” continued Lloyd, “I think I’ll run half of the distance I initially anticipated. Look, do you see this path here? I can easily tell that I won’t have to go there at all.”

“Is it a good thing that you don’t?”

“Yes, so do cheer me on, please.”

Lloyd then stepped out of the warehouse after stretching. Outside, 32-foot-sized Ppodong was waiting for him.

“Ppodong!”

“Where’s Ggoming?” asked Lloyd.

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!”

“His wing muscles are still sore?”

“Ppodong!”

“Okay,” said Lloyd. “It’s all right. He overworked himself traveling to the kingdom. I’m letting him rest for now.”

“Ppodong! Ppo-do-dong!”

“Okay, let’s go. Come one, Termes, please hop on.”

Lloyd and Termes hopped on Ppodong’s back. A smile escaped Lloyd as it had been quite a while since he sat on Ppodong’s fluffy and comfy back. Afterward, Ppodong sprinted westward, following the guidance of Termes, until they arrived at the closest underground tunnel to Kandara. Lloyd entered the tunnel and ran alone. The marathon to survey had begun.

“Huff, huff!”

Lloyd ran along the underground tunnel, lightly collecting his breath. Sometimes, the tunnel was straight. Sometimes, it was curved. Lloyd had the surveying skill activated throughout his run in the tunnel, and a torch was in his hand as if he was participating in an Olympic torch relay. *Crackle...!*

Countless pieces of information about the tunnel were collected.

My goodness. Never did I imagine before that I’d be doing something like this.

Running a marathon dozens of feet underground? A smile escaped Lloyd. At the same time, several memories came to his mind.

I remember when I first started learning how to sword fight.

It was around the time Lloyd tried to combat Sir Neumann, the traitor of his fiefdom. Lloyd worked on his stamina as he learned the basics of swordsmanship from Javier. That day, he had run more than the combined distance he ran in his life. But now, he was able to run faster and longer than before. It was thanks to the Asrahan Core Technique utilizing the triple circle and his manaheart which was close to the level of a mid-level sword expert.

“Huff! Huff!”

When was the last time I ran this much? Oh, right. The wild ants.

It must have been when he constructed the coal mine in his fiefdom. The last face of the mine touched the underground tunnels of the wild ants, which had Lloyd sprint and dash through the tunnels to attract the ants away from his people.

This reminds me of that time.

Lloyd scoffed again, putting an end to his reminiscing. And before he knew it, he was already near the end of the tunnel. He then studied the map.

Good. I think I can build the waterway according to the route I've run. I'll also block here, here, and here to prevent water from flowing out in another direction.

Lloyd then quickly checked several points of the map. Around an hour or two later, he finished surveying one underground tunnel. And then...

"Let's get moving again."

"Ppodong!"

He got on Ppodong again and moved to the next tunnel under Termes's guidance. Of course, Lloyd didn't rest in between the two tunnels. He precisely measured the course of the first and second tunnels, gauging and calculating the shortest route to connect them. In no time, he arrived at the second tunnel.

"Please wait here with Ppodong until I come back. If you're bored, play a word game with him," suggested Lloyd.

"What's a word game?" asked Termes.

"I'll show you. Ppodong?"

"Ppodong?"

"Why don't you start?"

"Ppodong!"

"Now," said Lloyd, "the next word you should say has to start with the letter 'D.'"

Lloyd looked at Termes, and the latter mumbled something.

"E…Expand."

"Hey, Ppodong. Your turn."

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“Ppodong said, ‘Painter.’ But since he can only say ‘Ppodong,’ your word must start with a ‘D’ every time. Got it?”

“...”

This is cheating, Termes wanted to rebut. But Lloyd had already dashed into the tunnel without waiting to start surveying again. Now, left all alone, Termes was forced to say the following as he turned to look at Ppodong.

“Whew. Dinner.”

“Ppodong!”

“Destroy.”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“...”

For some reason, Termes felt like he was in a more challenging battle than one against the sultan.

***

Slash!

“Argh...! Ugh!”

A giant wall. One that was so tall, its peak couldn’t be seen. Is this what it felt like to be blocked by such a wall? Sheherazade shuddered at the pang of stifling helplessness. But she wielded her sword again.

“Tssk!”

Whoosh! High-level sword expert. She had trained with all of her might to get to this level, so her attack contained all the years of her blood and sweat.

So, she had always been confident with her sword until she was faced with this opponent.

Boom!

“...!”

She missed. Not even a scrape. Her attack posed no threat.

How?

Her black-pearly eyes trembled, and her gaze quickly traced the trajectory of her opponent. She immediately braced herself for a possible counterattack. But her opponent didn’t fight back. Instead, he simply stepped back from the sword strike trajectory.

“Are you making fun of me?!”

As her shaky voice boomed in the room, her opponent, Javier, replied with a face void of any emotion.

“Not at all.”

“Then?”

“I told you,” Javier said, “I am simply following Master Lloyd’s order.”

“That ridiculous order to lock me up here?”

“He did not order me to lock you up here. He simply told me to take good care of you,” stated Javier tonelessly.

“That’s the same thing!”

Slash! Swish! Provoked, Sheherazade took two steps forward, laying two attacks as she broke the rhythm of her movement. The scimitar, the curved sword used in desert regions, split the space diagonally. The timing of her attack was perfect as it capitalized on the split second in between breathing. Had the opponent been an ordinary swordsman or a high-level sword expert

knight of a similar caliber, she would have caught him off guard well enough. But unfortunately, she was up against Javier.

“...”

Rustle. A half step back without a blink of an eye. That was all that was enough for Javier to make Sheherazade’s calculated attack meaningless. Her sword missed and sliced a nearby table and the back of a chair.

“Take care of me?” huffed Sheherazade. “Don’t be ridiculous. I’m a guard. Assigned by the sultan!”

“I know,” answered Javier, his voice dripping with composure.

“Then why are you doing this to me?!”

“Again, I am doing this at the order of Master Lloyd.”

“What did he say?!”

“That the desert sun is not good for your skin.”

“What...?” Sheherazade, who was breathlessly attacking Javier, stopped for the first time.

“What did you just say?” she asked as her brow shook.

“I am relaying exactly what Master Lloyd had said. Verbatim.”

“What now-”

“He said that the radiation from the desert sun accelerates skin aging and that the dry air in this area makes it the worst. The fine dust is also harmful to the respiratory system, and in the long term, it increases the chances of various kinds of lung conditions, according to him.”

“...”

What does that suppose to mean? She listened to Javier, feeling slightly dazed.

“Frankly, I do not know what radiation is either. And to be honest, I am not so happy about holding you here through the afternoon.”

“Then why won’t you let me out?” demanded Sheherazade.

“Again, I am doing this at the order of Master Lloyd.”

“That! That again!”

Provoked again, she gripped her scimitar hard, a part of her heart growing heavily anxious.

No. I can’t continue wasting my time like this.

She has been locked up in this room for several days now. In the afternoon, Javier stopped her from leaving. At night, Lloyd visited and spewed enchanting, enigmatic words that sounded like a spell. Lloyd didn’t give her even the slightest chance to strike up anything close to a conversation. Just hearing him talk brought a flood, a tsunami of sleepiness. She resisted by widening her eyes and firmly pinching her thighs. But eventually, she found herself sleeping in bed against her will. It was one of the best and most comfortable nights of sleep she ever had.

That’s the problem!

She enjoyed having a peaceful night of sleep. But once she woke up, it was already bright in the morning. There was no trace of Lloyd. Instead, there was sword master Javier at the door, blocking her from leaving just like today, right now. In other words, she was completely imprisoned day and night.

This is intentional. They’re confining me here on purpose. I don’t know why. But I’m certain that they’re trying to cast me aside.

And so, she was on edge. This was one of the rare chances the sultan offered her. She had the chance to satisfy his expectations. If she could

make Lloyd Frontera hers and bring him as the sultan’s son-in-law, she could be properly acknowledged by her father for the first time.

I can’t... I can’t miss such a precious opportunity!

She had to step out of this room. She had to be on Lloyd’s side as his guard and naturally spend more time with him. So, escaping this sickening room was the first thing to do! Sheherazade brandished her sword as she gritted her teeth, but she failed to reach her opponent. She couldn’t touch any part of him, not even a strand of his hair or an edge of his sleeves. It was even the case when Javier wasn’t attacking back at all. Worse, he was barehanded and moved only within a two-step perimeter. That fact made her even more frustrated.

“Arghhh! Please! Come on!”

Be captured. Be hit by my sword. She swung and struggled as she wailed desperately. Of course, Javier rejected her plea flatly, avoiding her attack much too easily. At the same time, he looked at her with a strange gaze.

“...”

Javier then remembered what Lloyd had hinted to him about her. How she was actually the daughter of the sultan. How she was here with ulterior motives. So, Lloyd suggested it was better to confine her here in this room lest she does something. It was only for the better that the sultan's daughter did not meet the rebels. Javier recalled the warning from Lloyd.

Well, at her skill level, this is a good training opportunity for you too.

His gaze toward her deepened. She was a high-level sword expert, which was far below his own status. Even so, there was a uniquely sharp ferocity in her sword movements that made her opponents flinch in fear.

What a talented woman.

Javier was impressed, but he didn’t show it. Not everyone could swing a sword with this much vigor. It wasn’t something that could be achieved by

simply leveling up.

It is a matter of talent.

Looking at talent alone, Javier figured she would be on par with Queen Magentano. If she met a good teacher and had the right opportunity, she would be able to rise to the level of a sword master.

Master Lloyd must be aware of it as well.

A crease appeared on his forehead. Master Lloyd was a quick-witted man, and it was only obvious that he saw through what potential this lady, who was going berserk now, had for herself. And yet, why did he put me to her side to jail her? wondered Javier. And he remembered how Lloyd had added that he could teach her a lesson if necessary. It didn't matter whether he showed what true sword fighting was. Lloyd had said those words as he scoffed.

"..."

What would happen, Javier wondered, if this lady became a sword master as she fought against him? The daughter of the sultan. The princess of the enemy kingdom. Should such a woman become a sword master, it would only mean more power for the enemy state.

Still, if he entrusted the job to me... I must only assume that Master Lloyd has a bigger plan in mind.

Javier decided to trust him. The Lloyd he knew until now would have a trustworthy plan in mind.

Then, I will help you out with your plan.

Javier made a decision. He would teach her a lesson. With that, Javier grabbed a candlelight hanging on a wall.

Clang! His candlelight easily blocked her scimitar, embers sparking at the blow.

“...!”

Her eyes widened in surprise. Javier’s eyes flashed with iciness. From that moment on, Sheherazade sincerely regretted her childhood decision to pursue the solitary path of sword fighting.

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Chapter 195: Drillers (2)

"Once upon a time, a long, long time ago, the water quality of the treated water was comparatively good, and the slow filtration method was adopted when the E. coli group was less than 1,000 (100mL, MPN), biological oxygen demand (BOD) was less than 2 mg/L, and the maximum turbidity was less than 10 degrees."

“Hold on...”

“Raw water treatment method aims at removing small amounts of turbidity and traces of organic matter from raw groundwater, eutrophication-free dam water, lake water, and pollution-free river water. The slow filtration method slowly filters raw water through a relatively thin layer of sand...”

“St...op...”

“This action also removes trace amounts of ammonia nitrogen, manganese, bacteria, and odor substances from the turbidity. Sedimentation paper is unnecessary at a maximum turbidity of 50°F or less per year, normal sedimentation paper is installed at a maximum turbidity of 50°F to 86°F per year, and a sedimentation paper capable of drug treatment is installed at a maximum turbidity of 50°F or higher per year.”

Zzz... Sheherazade’s head roughly jerked back, and her snores rang aloud the room. A satisfied smile appeared on Lloyd’s mouth.

Perfect.

Judging by how she fell asleep, it was obvious that the afternoon had been exhausting for her. Probably due to Javier’s strenuous sword lessons. Lloyd turned and looked at Javier, who was standing beside him, and then, he motioned a message with his hand.

“It’s over. Open your ears.”

Javier reacted to the hand motion by opening his ears which he had purposefully blocked off.

“Is it over?” asked Javier.

“Yeah. Why, did you want to listen to the lullaby as well?”

“No, not at all.” Javier shook his head with a serious look on his face.

The corners of Lloyd’s lips pulled further up mischievously.

“Not at all? Really? Truly?”

“Yes, without a doubt.”

“Be honest with me. I know you want to listen to my lullaby. Right?” insisted Lloyd.

“Not at all.”

“Just imagine it. You fall into a nice, peaceful sleep. And as the soft lullaby fills your ears, you slowly travel to your dreamland where pain or stress doesn’t exist. Completely relaxed. You’re so relaxed that even the dead skin on your feet let loose. It’s soothing. Warm. Comfortable. Fluffy. Imagine it in your head. Wow. Doesn’t it sound awesome?”

“...”

“Hey, did you know your eyes slightly closed just now?”

“...”

“My, my. No need to force them open now.”

“...”

“And now, you’re glowering at me.”

“Haah… Come on.”

Javier finally let out a sigh. He hated Lloyd. Hated him so much. If only he could, he wanted to flick Lloyd on the forehead. He would have done so if the latter wasn't his young master. But now, he didn't have any time to dwell on it. The time to work had arrived.

"So, do I have to repeat what I did yesterday?" asked Javier.

"Uh-huh."

Javier immediately put aside his boiling rage toward Lloyd and calmly asked about his tasks for the day in a professional manner. Lloyd nodded.

"You'll see the markings I made in the afternoon."

"Should the size and slope of the tunnels remain the same?" asked Javier again.

"Yeah. It's all marked the same as yesterday. So, you can just follow them as they are."

"Noted."

Javier got up from his seat and took his sword. Just like the past few days, he wore a robust leather vest on a comfortable shirt and put on a mask that would protect his nose and mouth from the thick layers of dust.

"I suggest you take a break for a bit," suggested Javier to Lloyd.

"Yeah. You should be careful too."

"Yes."

Master Lloyd will come out after an hour or two of sleep like usual. So, my job is to dig the designated areas until he comes back and drill the grounds exactly the way they are designed. Javier walked out of the room thinking so, heading to the field where excavation was taking place to build the Qanat. As he traveled there, the events that had taken place came to his mind one by one.

Has it been two months already?

It had been two months since he arrived in this city. In the first month, he had to spend his time shut inside the room. His daily routine involved dealing with Sheherazade while Lloyd was out surveying and designing. Thankfully, she didn't bore him. Their fights offered him an adequate warm-up exercise and a source of stimulation to improve his swordsmanship. Meanwhile, Lloyd finished surveying the underground tunnels and designing the Qanat. He had shared with Javier that he managed to design a short underground tunnel that would connect the intake station, which would be built at the foot of the western mountain range, to this city. The distance between them was about 23 miles.

The last time I had a proper night of sleep was a month ago.

In the second month of his stay, sleep came rare. The reason was simple. In the afternoon, he was forced to confine Sheherazade as he sword-fought her. At night, he headed to the construction field and dug tunnels. The toil placed a heavy burden on him, leading him to feel extreme fatigue. He even sometimes felt dizzy, and it was the case even when he owned the manaheart of massive density that surpassed any ordinary sword masters and supplemented his lacking stamina using the Asrahan Core Technique. But he barely gave a hang about exhaustion. No, he was actually enjoying this situation. Even when there was a way of knocking her cold fast and taking some breaks, he forced himself to melee for several hours and strained himself on purpose.

In the end, just overcoming extreme fatigue will also serve as a form of training for me.

He wouldn't relax just because he was a sword master. He would push his Asrahan Core Technique to higher levels. For that, he had to resort to extraordinary methods. A half-hearted effort wouldn't suffice. Javier was painfully aware of that fact. He once pushed the limits of being human to become a sword master, and now that he was aiming higher, he had to completely break free from the shackles of man. He had to overcome all the obstacles in his way. He had to defeat them. Reach where no one had ever reached. He was challenging himself to a level no one had ever treaded or

reached before. This was the transcendental level of power he was aiming for. So, he accepted that his current suffering and struggle were only natural. He resolved to push forward today like any other day and arrived at the construction site.

“I heard you can start the job from back there. Please follow me.”

Javier was guided by a man in the rebel group who was guarding the site. They walked the long path of the tunnel, and Javier spotted the traces of Lloyd’s work in the afternoon.

Master Lloyd is closing all the paths that won’t be used as the waterway.

Bricks and cement were noticeable throughout, blocking the path that was originally opened up. Javier postulated that it was to control the water inside the Qanat and prevent it from flowing elsewhere.

Master Lloyd must have put his nose to the grindstone all day.

To an untrained eye, those bricks and cement meant nothing. Just an object blocking the tunnel. But Javier was different. He had come to know how challenging waterproofing can get, thanks to his experiences in construction. The cement and brick walls looked simple to put up, but they were actually the results of hard work. They were the byproducts of countless geometrical calculations, careful deliberation, and seasoned experience. But it wasn’t only the design that was tricky. The construction part was the same. After all, a good design didn’t vouch for good results. That was why construction demanded much more care, effort, and deliberation than designing. First, the volcanic ash Bangul excreted must be gathered. Second, the cement must be mixed lest it cracks. Third, the size and angle of the bricks must be exact, not a single location or angle, or thickness wrong. No small gap or hole where water could leak into. Every process of stacking, plastering, and inspecting required thorough care.

I wonder where Master Lloyd learned all of this.

Master Lloyd was nothing but a party animal who liked to waste his years indulging in pleasure. Where did he learn these things without his and the

Frontera family’s knowledge?

Once, he gave me an excuse that he learned everything in a mysterious school in his dream.

A memory popped into Javier’s head just then. It was probably around when Viscount Lacona messed up the river and Lloyd constructed the water system to deal with the contaminated river. Javier had asked Lloyd where he had learned of all these. Lloyd answered in a joking manner that he dreamed about it. In a dream, he became a student at a mysterious university and learned all of these about construction. That was how he could do these things.

Could it be that he wasn’t joking?

During that time, Javier thought Lloyd was throwing a joke to fool him. But now, such a ridiculous answer sounded plausible.

“This is it.”

The voice of the rebel broke Javier’s trance, and he looked up. He was already at the end of the tunnel and saw various half-transparent signs marked on the wall. The dots, lines, lines, and sides glowed in faint blue. It was the guideline Lloyd had left for Javier. And on the side, he spotted a note. It was a memo instructing about the job.

[I’m going to get some sleep while you dig this. Good luck.]

“…”

Should I go back and punch his face? Javier tightened his grip on the sword.

***

The Qanat construction continued. The process was similar every day. When the sun was down, Javier headed to the construction site and dug following Lloyd’s construction guidelines. A mana blast, precise and controlled, was blasted each time his sword shone. A 65-foot hole was dug

in a flash. Its width was about 23 inches, and 3 feet in height. It was a narrow path suitable for only one person to pass through. It looked too narrow at first glance, but the fact was that the tunnel was dug to maximize the construction's efficiency and safety.

Of course. There's a higher chance of a collapse if the tunnel is dug wider than this.

The pressure inside the tunnel increased as it got wider. As a result, the chances of a collapse grew higher as the weight became too heavy to bear. That and Lloyd's goal to end this project as fast as possible were the reasons behind appropriately sizing the tunnels that would later become waterways. The tunnel sizes needed to meet only two criteria to be appropriate. The maximum size had to be independently strong enough to bear the load weight without any help from support structures, such as steel ribs, shotcretes, and rock bolts. At the same time, it had to contain enough space for a person to pass through for maintenance after the construction was complete. The result was a tunnel that was 23 inches in width and 3 feet in height. Of course, Lloyd had run a host of simulations before making this. He calculated the chances of each section collapsing after water flowed inside for several decades and centuries. He ran the tests countless times on the features of the soil and rocks existing in each section. Ultimately, it gave Javier even more work to do.

"Whew!"

The tunnel that was planned to be used as a waterway was too narrow. Javier had to squat down to move as it was not even 3 feet tall. And its 23 inches of width made it harder for him to turn around or use his sword. However, Javier, the Knight of Blood and Iron, didn't even grumble. He regarded this averse condition as another training exercise that would help him overcome his limits as a sword master.

Boom! Javier's mana blast extended the waterways with each burst. The extended channels connected with the main tunnel to create the shortest path possible. The connected waterways resembled underground capillaries. When Javier was finished digging through the night, Lloyd took up the baton and continued in the morning.

“Lalala! Lalalaa! Bangul!” exclaimed Lloyd.

“Bangul!”

Boom! Bangul’s volcanic ash was gathered and mixed into cement. And Lloyd closed several areas of the tunnel with cement and bricks to ensure the water didn’t take the wrong path.

If I don’t block them, it’s going to be a mess. If the water leaks somewhere odd and stagnates in a corner, it would become a breeding ground for germs.

Then the entire water of Qanat would be contaminated. In other words, the water that took so much pain to draw would become unusable. Thus, Lloyd tightly blocked every nook and corner of the underground tunnel that wouldn’t be used as a waterway. Just like that, the Knight of Blood and Iron blasted the tunnel while the Young Master sealed it. This process continued every day and night. Ten days. A fortnight. A month. Two months. The waterway that was first constructed near Kandara finally started to reach the foot of the mountain range in the west.

“Today, we are finally putting an end to this long construction project.”

On the day of the completion, Lloyd gathered Javier and the rebels in one place. He surveyed everyone at the upper ground of the mother well.

“It was not easy, but you all did a good job,” announced Lloyd in a serious voice.

A look of mixed emotions appeared on the faces of the rebels, including Termes. They had all worked together day and night covered in a thick layer of dust.

Of course. Without their help, the construction would have taken much longer.

Lloyd was grateful for the rebels. He wasn’t alone when he blocked the useless parts of the tunnels. These men had helped move all the cement and

bricks, and it was they who transferred the excavated soil outside the tunnel. Aside from that, they drilled countless vertical holes that were 65 feet deep and 328 feet apart from each other, which would be used as a passage to go down to the waterways for future maintenance and repair.

They gladly took those jobs.

Construction wasn't a one-man job. It required a host of workers teaming up and working together. Sometimes, in the process, quarrels and conflicts arose, and they fought over negligible profits and losses. But eventually, they had to work as one to complete the construction. That was the nature of construction work. That was what construction was.

"We all gladly covered ourselves in the dirt for our work until now. And so, I think we should enjoy the final moment of this construction together."

"Do you mean that we shovel all together at the end of the waterway?" Termes asked after Lloyd finished his speech.

"No, that's not the case. It's going to be a disaster if we do that," said Lloyd as he faintly smiled.

"Hmm? Disaster? What do you mean-"

"We'll die."

Termes became speechless. The corners of Lloyd's lips pulled further up.

"I don't know if you know," explained Lloyd, "but only a bedrock that's about 10 feet wide stands in between the end of our waterway and this mother well. But you see, that mother well goes deeper than 98 feet underground. Accordingly, it possesses a large amount of water and pressure."

"Then if we burst the bedrock and connect the waterway-"

"Yes, you're right. The water stagnating in the mother well will burst, sweeping the inside of the waterway with tremendous water pressure. You can imagine what would happen to the last person who bore the tunnel."

Lloyd paused and motioned, slitting his throat with his hand.

“That’ll be the end of him.”

Lloyd was speaking the truth. The water pressure from connecting the waterway and the mother well was intolerable for humans. It would lead to immediate death, nothing more or less. So, the ancient laborers who actually created the Qanat were...

“Do you have any other method in mind?” asked Termes.

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded. Of course, he had something in mind.

“I just need one volunteer to sacrifice.”

That was what the ancient workers did in the Middle East. The oldest laborer met his final moment when the Qanat was constructed. He pickaxed with dignity and composure, connecting the waterway and mother well. Then he died, sacrificing himself to give clean water to future generations and his descendants.

“However, well, we don’t need anyone to die.”

That was also obviously the case. This was not the ancient Middle East. This world was different. There wasn’t any need to sacrifice a healthy individual. This would be especially true if there was an entity that could do the job for them without getting harmed.

“Right?”

Lloyd grinned as he looked at the back of the rebel guys, who all turned back following his gaze. And beyond the mound of rocks in the mountain foot appeared a skull of a skeleton soldier whose neck was stuck out forward. And it shook its bony hand at everyone, making a finger heart sign like it had learned from Lloyd the other time.

Crack! It was Turtle Neck, the leader of the Skeleton Corps, that traveled from Frontera fiefdom and crossed the mountains and deserts to meet Lloyd.

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Chapter 196: Young Master Is a Top Gun (1)

Crack! Turtle Neck held out his hands and made a finger heart. Behind him appeared some more skeleton soldiers. They all followed their leader and shot a heart at everyone else. This was their way of expressing their joy of meeting Lloyd, their savior, for the first time in a while.

Whew... It was terribly difficult getting here.

Turtle Neck's third cervical vertebrae clacked. Just then, the long journey to get here crossed its mind. It must have been the following morning after Lloyd coldly left the fiefdom with the envoys.

"Boss!"

It happened in the morning when everyone woke up. They had been living in accordance with the construction schedule of the humans and the biorhythm marked in their marrows. It was around the time when they were soaking themselves under the sun, all dazed and blanked out, after opening their coffin lids. One of them raised its hand high, suddenly swaying its fingers and writing words in the air. A human would have had difficulty catching the meaning. But the rest of the skeletons understood in a breeze the meaning of its gesticulation. It was saying that it felt empty.

The rest of the skeletons nodded their skulls.

"Right. Me too."

"I feel the same. For some strange reason, I am agitated."

"I feel like the wind is blowing through my ribs."

"But it always has been like that."

"Oh, come on. I'm saying that's how I feel. You have no say when you have a smaller pelvis than me."

All the skeletons wrote something in the air. Some nodded. Some quarreled. But everyone expressed a similar sentiment. Later, Turtle Neck wrote a message in the air after observing them.

“I think I know why.”

“What is it? Do you know why, boss?”

“Tell us quickly.”

The rest of the skeletons stared at Turtle Neck like baby birds staring up at their mother. Turtle Neck clacked its lower jaw and laughed without any noise.

“It’s because Lloyd left us.”

“Oh! Ah...”

The rest of the skeletons nodded their skulls, and each wrote what they had to say.

“*What must we do, boss?”* one of them wrote hurriedly.

“*Should we bear this emptiness until Lloyd comes back?”*

“I don’t want to. I feel like I’ll develop osteoporosis at this rate.”

“*Right. I can’t live like this.”*

“Let’s do something!”

Their suppressed emotions burst out of them. The longing for their master and lifesaver, Lloyd. The emptiness due to his absence. They yearned to fill the hole in their hearts and find a solution. Turtle Neck struggled for some time to console its team.

“Come on now. Everyone, calm down. Getting all worked up is not healthy for your bones. You will lose your gloss, and your bones will age.”

“Then what do we do, boss?”

“I can’t say for sure. But I have an idea.”

“Tell us now!”

Everyone stared at Turtle Neck’s fingertip, and at last, it wrote its opinion in the air.

“We could go find Lloyd.”

“Oh! Oh!”

“But on one condition.” Turtle Neck wrote.

“Condition?”

“Yeah. I think it would be best if only a select few go find him.”

“Why? Why is that?”

Everyone cocked their skulls. Turtle Neck continued to write.

“Think about it. Lloyd is our master, so he isn’t afraid of us. And the people in this fiefdom heard from him about us, so they’re okay with us. But what about the others?”

“...”

“The moment they lay their sight on us, they will panic and go berserk. They will run away in fear or come attack us. Is that what you all want?”

“No, it’s not.”

“Therefore...”

Turtle Neck began to move faster.

“We must stay low and away from people’s sight as much as possible. But if 200 of us move all at once, the chance of being seen gets higher. That is why we should choose a few of us to look for Lloyd.”

“Are we going there to help Lloyd’s work?”

“Yes.”

Turtle Neck nodded once again.

“Lloyd should be constructing something somewhere. I don’t know why, but I just can feel it. He was always like that. But it hardly matters if he isn’t. Anyway, let us pick the elite among us. About 20. Only they will go find Lloyd and help him out. How does that sound?”

“What about the others?”

“We can’t do anything about them. They will have to be content with cheering on those who are selected to go.”

Turtle Neck adamantly expressed its opinion. There was no opposition. There was about a ten percent chance for a skeleton to be selected. If one got selected, it was set to meet Master Lloyd. If not, it was set to stay under the sun as its bones grew dry. But there wasn’t any other option. After all, their leader, Turtle Neck, was always right.

“Okay. I’m in!”

“Aye!”

“Let’s hurry, and pick who will go!”

Everyone agreed. The process of selecting the team was simple and swift.

“Okay, group into 20 and pick a leader. The leaders will do a fair game of rock, paper, scissors!”

“Paper!”

After several rounds and many groans, 20 skeletons were selected at last. They were Turtle Neck, Frozen Shoulder, and 18 other members.

“I leave the command to you Square Jaw while I am gone.”

“Aw... Okay, say hi to Lloyd for us, boss.”

“I will.”

Just like that, Turtle Neck, Frozen Shoulder, and 18 other skeleton soldiers picked up a shovel and left the Frontera fiefdom in the middle of the night. They didn't get lost during travel as they were bound to Lloyd by the Zombie Domination. Thanks to it, they could feel where Lloyd was as they moved.

“To the east!”

“Let’s goooo!”

They climbed the eastern mountain range. The journey wasn’t smooth sailing. A host of wild animals and monsters coveted their oily and nice-looking bones, particularly the pack of wolves that kept pestering them as they drooled. But the skeletons defeated them and safely climbed the eastern range until a wasteland without a drop of water appeared. The journey then turned out easy afterward. Why? They didn’t need any water in the first place.

“Wahaha! It’s so nice to bathe in the sun all day!”

They didn’t need any food or water. It went the same even if the desert spanned in front of them. This environment was way more comfortable because now, there was only a little risk of being seen by humans. Just like that, they traversed the desert. Sometimes, they had to travel past the oasis or villages. Even then, it wasn’t a problem. They simply spent their afternoon lazing around the dunes or pits. Even if people passed by, they simply clicked their tongues in pity, thinking that these skeletons must have belonged to those who perished after getting lost in the desert. With such

cover and disguise, they kept traveling. There was one time when Lloyd's location suddenly changed.

"Ugh? Lloyd just passed over us!"

"What? Really?"

"I saw it! It was Lloyd! He flew away riding Ggoming!"

There was a stir among them for a while. The location of Lloyd they felt in the eastern desert suddenly changed to Magentano, but the fuss lasted only a while. From the western to eastern desert, Lloyd flew over them again. From then on, they dutifully continued treading their path until today all safe and well after a long journey, no one left behind. Of course, Lloyd, too, was feeling the movement of the skeletons due to his skill.

Oh, you precious little skeletons.

Lloyd swelled with pride and contentment as he gazed at Turtle Neck, Frozen Shoulder, and 18 skeleton soldiers that dared all the way to come here.

They don't demand food or fancy lodging. They don't get tired. They're skilled. Moreover, they don't even need to get paid! My, how can I not like you?

And not enough with that, they made it all the way here to lend a hand. How could Lloyd not cherish them? But such a sentiment wasn't shared by the rest of the rebels that looked at the Skeleton Corps.

"Eh?! Eh?"

"What is that?!"

Termes, the leader of the rebels, and the rest of the members were taken unawares. The appearance of Turtle Neck prompted them to raise their shovels and pickaxes by reflex. Hadn't Lloyd interfered at the right time, they would have charged at the skeletons.

“Woah, woah,” said Lloyd as he motioned with his hands. “Everyone calm down.”

Lloyd grabbed Termes’s shovel, and in a nonchalant face, he quickly turned around.

“Don’t be surprised. These friends of mine are very obedient,” said Lloyd.

“Those skeletons obey you...?”

“Yes.”

“Wait, are you a warlock?”

“Oh, no. I’m not.”

Lloyd’s smile turned more playful. “I have a backstory to this. Do you want to listen?”

“Oh...”

Termes and the others flinched in hesitation at Lloyd’s question, and their faces turned pale all of a sudden. It was because their minds flew back to the time when Lloyd talked for more than an hour when they kidnapped him. Termes shook his head quickly.

“No, no,” Termes said. “I don’t think I need to hear your explanation.”

“Right?” agreed Lloyd. “We are close enough to skip those formalities.”

“You are right. Yes, yes, of course,” said Termes as he plastered a hurried and awkward smile on his face.

Lloyd flashed a satisfied smile and said, “I am glad that you trust me. Anyway, they don’t bite. They won’t beat or hurt you. They are dutiful and nice, so they are obedient to me.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes, you see, they are regular workers of my fiefdom.”

More than that, they were star workers. With Lloyd’s introduction, Turtle Neck, Frozen Shoulder, and the rest of the skeletons carried their shovels on their shoulder bones with pride. Now that their appearance was explained, Lloyd spoke.

“Anyway, it’s a relief that the talent to penetrate the water vein of the waterway came just in time.”

Lloyd spoke and grinned, tapping Turtle Neck’s shoulder. Everyone’s eyes widened in surprise.

“Wait, are you saying that the skeleton soldiers will break the last vein of water?”

“Yes. That way, no one will die.”

It was obviously the case. Breaking a vein of water in the Qanat was extremely dangerous. How dangerous? The chance of dying was 100%. In other words, anyone who tried was guaranteed death. So, that was the reason why this step of construction was given to the oldest laborers in the ancient Middle East. No, it wasn’t given per se. They volunteered to give their lives away to provide the young ones and their descendants with clean water. But here? That wasn’t necessary.

“Turtle Neck and the others here will be assigned the vein water task.”

“I-is that okay for them?” mumbled Termes.

“Yes, well. But we should at least install a net downstream of the waterway. That way they don’t lose their bones.”

“...”

Everyone nodded, slightly overwhelmed. Just like that, the last operation was done. Several layers of nets and frames were installed downstream. Next, Turtle Neck, Frozen Shoulder, and the skeleton soldiers were brought into action.

“Okay, do you see the guideline direction from here?” asked Lloyd. “Just dig along the line.”

Crack! The skeletons nodded their skulls as they held up the shovels and pickaxes. Then they restlessly smite and dug bedrock. A long while later, at last, the vein of water exploded.

“...!”

Boooom! Water gushed out and its terrifying pressure disassembled the skeleton soldiers’ bones within a nanosecond, sweeping them away with a fierce current. Thankfully, every single joint was caught in the net. Even after that, the water continued to flow along the waterway.

Fwoosh! Past underground tunnels of the vast and desolate deserts, through the exactly calculated path, the water arrived at the destination. The end of the Qanat. The clean water flowed from the filtration plant that sat in a corner of Kandara. The water had melted from the permanent snowline in the mountain 23 miles away from the city.

“It’s water! There is water flowing out!”

People of Kandara shouted in excitement as the stream of water filled the filtration plant in no time. In truth, they didn't have much faith in Lloyd before and thought that he was nothing but the sultan’s stool pigeon. That was until the rebels came to clear the misunderstanding, telling them how Lloyd was actually a noble from a kingdom far west and came to solve the drought. They enlightened the people on what was happening.

But still, people remained skeptical about the part of drawing water to their homes. Drawing water from a distant mountain? They thought that it was impossible. A false hope. Such doubt dominated their hearts. After all, this place was abandoned even by their ruler, the sultan himself. The city administrator had long left this city to save his own life as well. And what? A young noble from a foreign country would come to help out? Everyone became united to not expect too much as it will only bring bigger disappointments. They were preparing themselves for the possibility of getting disappointed one day.

But it turned out they were wrong. Lloyd's bravado turned out to be true. Everything that he said happened. The cold water in their hands. The freshwater the city's mothers, daughters, fathers, and sons drank in relief proved so.

It's a relief.

Lloyd smiled in satisfaction as he gazed at the people who now had an infinite source of water amid the drought. But he didn't explicitly shout in happiness like the people. It was too early to dance in joy. He still needed to check the other destinations of the waterway.

The waterway of Qanat doesn't end here. I need to check them all.

Lloyd recalled the construction contract he had signed with the sultan. The contract promised to solve the drought in the entire Kandahar region using the Qanat. But this Kandara city was merely the central city of the region. It wasn't the entire region. And so...

That's why I didn't blindly close all the rebel's tunnels in the first place.

Lloyd only blocked the unnecessary areas after doing some careful calculations and running a simulation. And so, the waterway was designed to even flow into the small cities and villages of Kandahar region like spider webs or blood vessels.

"So, Termes, please come with me," suggested Lloyd.

"Where to?"

"To the small cities and villages."

The people there won't know yet about the existence of the Qanat. So, Lloyd needed to personally fly with Termes and explain to the people that clean water is now available through the rebels' underground tunnels and that they only have to draw water for drinking and farming. Lloyd would then be able to tell the sultan that he fulfilled the duties in the contract.

"Let us go then."

From then on, Lloyd traveled to the small cities and villages in the region, and it took well over three days. He enlightened the people in detail of the Qanat and how to use and manage it. The moment the final village was visited, a rewarding message appeared on Lloyd's eyes.

Ding dong.

[You have accomplished the great feat of connecting miraculous streams of water in the middle of the arid desert with your exceptional wits, bold negotiation skills, and accurate and persistent construction method.]

[The people of Kandahar region who have suffered from the prolonged drought praise you very much.]

[You have earned a new title.]

[A new title <Top Gun from the West> has been created.]

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Chapter 197: Young Master Is a Top Gun (2)

Ding dong.

[A new title <Top Gun from the West> has been created.]

Woo!

A series of messages appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes, and he secretly clenched his fists. He held a bounty of successful experiences and earned various accomplishments and titles from them. So this time, he had also been expecting a decent tribute to come out.

Rather, I'd be upset if these messages didn't appear before me anymore.

The construction took over a whopping four months, which meant that he had to give up his spring season in this scorching and arid desert. As such, it would be only natural to receive a reward. Lloyd's eyes rolled down in anticipation.

[Top Gun from the West]

[Title Level: Regional Hero Tale]

There's no water. We're thirsty. Sultan abandoned us. Even the administrator fled away. No help came our way. That seemed to be it. That seemed to be it without change. All may perish, but nothing will change. Everyone gave up. That was the reason. When a young master from a neighboring country woke us up When he gave us water stressing it was coming from him, What a strange man he is, we thought. What a creepy man he is, we thought. We never knew then. That this young master will never give up on us. That he would toil covered in the sand all day when the sultan and administrator abandoned us. So, what happened now? Allow me to ask you a question first. My dear customer, would you like some tea?

[Compliment Effect: You have become the lifesaver and hero of the entire region by solving the chronic drought that plagued the Kandahar region.

Your tale will spread to all corners of the desert. The shamans of desert tribes in the world bless your name with gratitude and respect. Thanks to it, you will not experience dehydration in any situation in the regions of the complement influence.]

[Title Region: All desert regions. All areas whose annual average climate is 104 °F and above.]

[Active Period of Title: 300 Years.]

[A title's powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region for which the compliment was given. Moreover, time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 4]

[Current CP: 614]

Wow.

Lloyd exclaimed in pure amazement after reading the title description. He couldn't help it.

I'm immune to dehydration?

The title only worked in hellish deserts and other regions where the climate went above 104 °F on average. It would have been better if it included all regions instead of only the deserts but was still a tremendous skill. Dehydration. It was rare to find any other symptom that could take one's life away so easily.

Of course. We die when we lose about 12% of the water from our bodies. Furthermore, dehydration is not uncommon.

Vomiting and diarrhea from a nasty illness. Not drinking water after sweating much. Or getting lost in the desert. Any of those events could cause dehydration in the body. But now, Lloyd was immune to it, and he wouldn't die in the desert because of it at least.

Not only in the desert, though. I mean, I could fall in hell out of great misfortune, but even then, I'd be okay.

But, well, it was apparent such a thing wouldn't happen. Lloyd shrugged his shoulders and proceeded to focus on the joy of earning a new tribute. However, his joy didn't end there. Aside from the tribute message in front of his eyes, more praises and tributes continued to appear.

"Mister! Water!"

Right after Lloyd returned from teaching people in the small provinces how to use the Qanat, someone shouted at him as he entered the downtown. The voice belonged to a five or six-year-old child, who came sprinting toward Lloyd. And the boy held out the wooden cup to Lloyd.

Slosh! Half of the water splashed out, soaking Lloyd's pants.

"Eek?!"

Lloyd was surprised by the sudden splash, but he didn't blame the boy because the boy's eyes glimmered so brightly.

"Water!"

"You want me to drink it...?" asked Lloyd.

"Yes!"

"Is this mine?"

"Yes!"

The boy, whose blushed cheeks were full like a dumpling, continued to speak, his dark eyes glimmering all the more.

"Mom said! You gave Selim water!" the boy cried out.

"Oh, your name is Selim?"

“Yes!”

“Then Selim, are you gifting this water to me?”

“Yes! Mom said you must be thirsty too!”

“...”

Lloyd took the cup, which was almost empty, and slowly drank from it, feeling several gazes watching him. Countless people of Kandara were gathered and looking at him. Some with a content gaze. Some clapping. Each and everyone was expressing their gratitude and favor in their own way.

“...”

I just did what I had to do to achieve my goal, which was to start the talks and prevent war with the sultan kingdom, Lloyd thought to himself. He started this project to ensure a comfortable life for himself and no one else. So, he was unsure if he deserved this kind of treatment.

It’s strange. This feeling.

Lloyd was shy. At the same time, he was ashamed and apologetic. He particularly felt that way toward Termes and the rest of the rebels.

“You know... You should have been the ones to be applauded and praised by the people. Not me.”

Later that night, Lloyd expressed his feelings to Termes.

“Since you all have conducted various activities against the sultan who gave this region up. You funded and bought water for the people in need and endlessly worked to restore the wells abandoned by the regional administrators who ran away.”

Lloyd was telling the truth, but they actually did more than that. The rebels struggled hard to convince the regional emirs of the redistribution of the prosperity and wealth concentrated in Ahinsya and argued that the scattered

regional military power must be brought together to press the sultan. They tenaciously clamored to get help from the emirs.

“But we weren’t able to provide water to the entire region like now,” Termes chuckled as he turned to Lloyd.

Termes was in traveling clothes now. But he wasn’t alone. The rebel executives and their families were all wearing robust traveling clothes. They loaded a handful of items needed for a long camelback journey as they were defecting to the Frontera fiefdom tonight.

“It is true that we tried,” said Termes. “But we failed to be as successful. So, you don’t have to apologize. We should be grateful instead.”

The corners of Termes’s lips pulled further up before continuing. “You gave the people in this region a new life. Not only that, you gave us a new land in your fiefdom where we can start anew. Everything you said when you were abducted all came true.”

“Termes,” said Lloyd.

“Thank you. You are our lifesaver. So...”

Flop. Termes got down on his knee, and the rest of the rebels did the same. Everyone then politely bowed their heads.

“I, the son of Murat Termes, and the people of Damieta Termes vow unchanging allegiance to you, Lloyd Frontera, until we breathe last.”

Woah.

There was no time to stop them. Termes got down on his knee in a flash and vowed his allegiance to Lloyd. Simultaneously, another message appeared in front of his eyes.

Ding dong.

[Damieta Termes has opened his heart to you.]

[The rebel leader of the sultan kingdom, Damieta Termes, vowed his allegiance to you.]

[Damieta Termes will forever be grateful to you and gladly follow you until your death.]

[From now on, you can increase likeability and earn RP from him.]

[50 RP has been rewarded for forming a new connection with another human.]

[Current RP: 2,755]

[Your likeability with Damieta Termes has increased by 11 points.]

[Current RP with Damieta Termes: +61]

[You have earned 77 RP by improving your relationship with a character.]

[Current RP: 2,832]

[Moreover, the likeability of the men and women of Damieta Termes, who vowed allegiance with him, will be included in the average likeability of all the Frontera fiefdom residents.]

Woah.

A title, likeability, and RP? Is it my birthday or something? Lloyd quickly pulled himself together, forcing down the corners of his lips that were pulling up to his ears. And laboriously ignoring Turtle Neck's message that real allegiance comes after death, Lloyd looked at Termes and the rest of the rebels.

"Thank you, everyone..."

When someone expresses or hands out something with a genuine heart, you must do the same. Or you must pretend to act so. That's the polite thing to do. So Lloyd accepted Termes's vow of allegiance in a serious expression, gaze, and voice.

“I will do my best to not let you all down as well,” said Lloyd solemnly.

“Lord...”

“The night will be cold. Be safe on your way back to Frontera fiefdom.”

“Yes, my lord,” said Termes. “We will leave first.”

“Yes. Turtle Neck?”

Crack! At Lloyd’s calling, Turtle Neck stepped forward fast.

“From now on, I want you and Skeleton Corps to guide them. You can do a good job, can’t you?”

Crack! Turtle Neck nodded its skull energetically. It and its team had already once traversed the desert, and such experience allowed them to completely master which road was risky and safe for humans. Moreover, Termes and the rest of the rebels had been born and raised in the desert. The reliable guide that was the Skeleton Corps. The travelers native to the deserts. The two were a wonderful combination. So, there wasn’t anything to worry about regarding their journey to the fiefdom. And just like that, the Skeleton Corp, Termes, and the rest of the rebels set out on their long journey. Lloyd finally sighed in relief as he felt a weight taken off his shoulder.

“Whew.”

Lloyd was used to receiving compliments from the messages, but it was a slightly different scenario to get praised in person by real people. It was uncomfortable and made him shy. He even felt embarrassed to a degree. His heart was eased when he shamelessly went around and showed off his charitable actions to the city’s people to get cooperation from the rebels.

But now that the stage is set, it’s really embarrassing to hear real praises. I’m not making any sense.

A wry smile escaped Lloyd, and soon, he headed back to his lodging again to get ready to leave for Ahinsya the next day. But when he got there, the

string of praises that agonized Lloyd continued. The next up in line was surprisingly a member of the delegation the sultan had assigned to him.

“I sincerely respect you, Master Lloyd.”

“...”

What’s the deal with this man now? Lloyd wondered as he stood in the hallway of his room. Lloyd stared at the head of the delegation with a gutted face.

“Actually, I knew this from the beginning,” confessed the delegation head with a serious look on his face. He seemed to be early in his 40s. “How else could I not? That you are constructing with the help of the rebels here.”

“Oh... Did you?” mumbled Lloyd.

“Yes,” the delegation head said as he nodded. “We, too, have eyes and ears. So we contemplated about this matter whether we should stop and report you to the sultan that you joined hands with those that oppose him. But we didn’t. Actually, we thought we shouldn’t.”

“Why is that?” asked Lloyd.

“Since completing the Qanat you are working on will stabilize the lives of the people in this region, which will benefit the sultan in the long run.”

“I suppose,” replied Lloyd, “you saw turning a blind eye is a way to be loyal to the sultan in the grander scheme of things?”

“Business-wise, yes. But personally, no.”

“What do you mean about the latter?” asked Lloyd, intrigued.

“I personally came to respect you.”

...*Cough!*

“I respect you, Master Lloyd.”

“Ah... I understand. You know, you can let go of your hand...”

“Can I hold them for ten more seconds? I want to tell proudly tell my son about how I held the hands of a wise man once I get back to Ahinsya.”

“Suuure...”

He got goosebumps all over his body. It was more than toe-curling. His hands, feet, neurons, and every hair and cell in his whole body curled in embarrassment. But Lloyd held up, pushing himself with sheer willpower, and endured the uncomfortable and shiny gaze this middle-aged man was shooting at Lloyd. Making things worse, Lloyd even signed the autograph when the latter held out a piece of paper.

Oh, crap. Why is it that I keep being liked by smelly old men? Come on.

Case in point, Lloyd had a group of father-in-law candidates who wanted him as their son-in-law. It was also the case for the men who bore their hearts out so easily and told him that they respect him. The more he thought about it, the deeper he was plunged into sorrow.

With the same thought in his mind, Lloyd and the others left Kandara the next day while the people cheerfully saw them off. And for several days, Lloyd lived through the coldness of the desert at night and rode camelback for several days until he arrived at Ahinsya, the capital of the sultan's kingdom. But Lloyd’s popularity didn’t dwindle here. The most powerful man among the father-in-law candidates was waiting in the palace.

“How come you are not my son-in-law...?”

Sultan Samarkhan, with a fiery gaze and gritting teeth, demanded Lloyd when the latter went to the palace to give a report on the Qanat construction.

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Chapter 198: A Cunning Man’s Survival Tactic (1)

“How come you are still not my son-in-law...?”

“Your Majesty...?”

The sultan’s question sounded like a blaze of fire as it rang beneath his throne. Shocked, Lloyd almost jerked his head up and committed the mistake of looking at the sultan. Lloyd swallowed.

What the heck? This guy’s more uptight than I thought.

He couldn’t help but form such ideas about the sultan because, after all, he came to report the good news that the construction was over and that the Kandahar region was free from drought. But here came the sultan, spewing this nonsense as soon as he laid his eyes on Lloyd.

How should I answer this?

Lloyd was flustered and wondered how he should respond to the sultan’s overly straightforward question. What reaction would save him from this distressing situation? Around the time Lloyd was thinking deeper about the matter...

“What are you so surprised about?”

Lloyd heard the sultan chuckling.

“Lloyd Frontera, the son of Arcos Frontera, what ruler in this world would discover a talent like you and not become greedy after finding out you are unmarried?” said the sultan.

“Oh...”

“I was expressing my wish. That is it. I presume you did not like my daughter very much.”

“Did you notice that I figured it out already, Your Majesty?”

“She told me the details.”

“...”

Lloyd clamped his mouth shut. It looked like Sheherazade had already met with the sultan and reported everything as soon as she was back.

I hope she didn’t twist the story in her favor.

Lloyd remained silent, feeling antsy.

“An affair between a man and a woman,” the sultan went on, “cannot be forced if they do not see eye to eye regardless of what I think. Therefore, I simply spoke my wish out loud, so do not be too bothered.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“You can be grateful to Your Majesty in your kingdom, not me.”

“...”

Lloyd suddenly felt he was getting scolded. However, to his relief, the sultan didn’t stay on the subject for long.

“Now,” the sultan said, “let’s discuss more important matters. Have you completed the Qanat?”

“Yes, oh, great and omnipotent sultan.”

Lloyd, who direly wanted the subject to change, answered swiftly without missing a beat.

“After four months of construction, I was able to draw water from the foot of the mountain. It was all thanks to my efforts as I strove hard to fulfill the contract with the great and omnipotent sultan. Moreover, thanks to it, Kandara and most villages in the Kandahar region are supplied with water. Again, it was all thanks to my efforts as I strove hard to fulfill the contract with the great and omnipotent sultan.”

“So, the credit is due to your effort...?” asked the sultan, his voice slightly dumbstruck.

“I simply strove hard to fulfill the contract with the great and omnipotent sultan.”

“It sounds like you are warning me to fulfill our contract terms,” the sultan accused.

“How could a mere peasant as I dare do that, Your Majesty?”

“I think you are.”

“Not at all, Your Majesty,” denied Lloyd persistently. “As the great and omnipotent sultan is great and omnipotent, I have no inkling of doubt that Your Majesty will easily fulfill the contract terms Your Majesty made with a worthless man like me. Given that, there is no need for me to voice such a ludicrous statement.”

“I see... You are telling me to sit at the negotiation table with the Magentano envoys.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“Tsk.”

Sultan Samarkhan clucked his tongue. What a competent and shameless fellow Lloyd was! And yet, he couldn’t hate Lloyd. It was the opposite. He wanted Lloyd even more.

How wonderful it would be if he were my son-in-law.

If Lloyd became his son-in-law, he thought about making the former his right-hand man and using all his talent to change the future of the sultan kingdom.

Alicia Termina Magentano. I wonder why that foolish woman isn’t actively using such a talented man.

Samarkhan wished that she would hand over Lloyd to him if she was going to waste his talent. He couldn't suppress the thought of it. That was how direly the sultan wanted Lloyd, who solved the drought in the Kandahar region. Not only that, there was the detailed report of Sheherazade and the delegation that went there with Lloyd.

I heard he received cooperation from the rebels. And after bringing the project to success, he even sent the rebels to an area my powers can't reach.

The sultan almost clapped in amazement when he heard the report. That was how perfectly Lloyd did his job. Lloyd, the rebels, the people of Kandahar, and the sultan himself all benefited from his actions. It was that aspect of Lloyd that the sultan liked.

He's not just good at his job or intelligent. He's different from those that learned about the world through books.

His plan would've been impossible for mere bookworms to execute. It could only be done by someone who suffered through the tribulations of life. The sultan's eyes held a glint of desire as they looked at Lloyd. But it soon disappeared to be replaced with a heavy gaze befitting his status as the desert's ruler.

"I see," said the sultan, his voice now sounding like a ruler of the deserts. "The exchange between us was a clear promise and contract. Since you fulfilled your part, it is now my turn. I declare that I will meet the Magentano envoys tomorrow."

"I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty."

"I told you. You should be grateful to Your Majesty in your kingdom, not here."

The sultan then chuckled and told Lloyd to leave now. After Lloyd was gone, the sultan glanced at the place where Lloyd was a moment ago.

"..."

Samarkhan felt bad that Lloyd was leaving. He was regretful seeing Lloyd slip out of his hands like this. So...

Let’s give it one more try.

The sultan nodded to himself slowly, and his eyes gradually reflected determination.

***

The sultan fulfilled his promise the following day. The negotiation took off, and Count Ventura entered the palace with a grim look on his face. The palace was unusually calm and quiet that day. There was something different about its atmosphere, something different from the usual air of somberness. Everyone waited for the results with bated breaths. Only the sultan and the envoy's head entered the room. The others waited in anxiety about what would happen once the room doors opened up. The delegation. The sultan’s officials. The people of Ahinsya. Everyone felt the same except for one person.

“Master Lloyd, I suppose you are not too concerned.”

“Uh-huh.”

Lloyd nodded his head earnestly as if any other reaction was strange. Then he sucked the straw in his mouth hard. *Slurp!*

The juice of the coconut, which only grew in the nearby regions of Ahinsya, flowed through the straw to enter his mouth. It was sweet and sour. Salty and nutty. Cool and refreshing.

“This is what life’s about!”

The taste was too good not to let out an exclamation. The fruit cost one gold ring to just buy one, and the taste reflected its price. It made sense why even the royal emirs sparingly enjoyed this high-end and exquisite fruity flavor.

If I were to compare, I’d say this tastes similar to fresh, fizzy Coke.

Lloyd couldn’t believe that he could get the taste of such a beverage in this world. He eyed the coconut as his heart overflowed with emotion. Then he licked his lips in regret that he couldn’t have this back in his fiefdom.

“Why should I care about the negotiation?” blurted Lloyd, “I’d rather drink this stuff to my heart’s content before I go back home. Don’t you think so?”

“No, I do not think so.” Javier frowned pathetically at Lloyd. “This negotiation can alter the history of the kingdom. If it goes wrong, a war could break out. So, I say it is only right that you care for it.”

“But what good will it do?” asked Lloyd innocently.

“Excuse me?”

“It’s not like I can butt in this negotiation. And the result is obvious, so what’s the point?”

“How is it obvious?” said Javier as he cocked his head.

Lloyd grinned. “It will go well. Inevitably so.”

“How can you be so certain?”

“The sultan no longer has the reason to wage war.”

It was true. The sultan had been anxious to the bone about his people turning their backs against him due to the drought that plagued the Kandahar region. He had intentionally decided to start a conflict with the Magentano kingdom to shift the public’s attention elsewhere. But now, the situation had changed.

“I found the solution to their drought,” drawled Lloyd, “and though it’s really up to the sultan how things will go down the road, right now, there’s little worry about people turning their back against him. From the sultan’s perspective, there’s no reason to go as far as to wage a diplomatic conflict and war.”

“Then...”

“It’s most likely that he will acknowledge his responsibility for the Monster Domino incident,” said Lloyd.

A brow lifted on Javier’s face. “Then can I ask you one more thing?”

“Yes, what is it?”

“If the conclusion was so obvious to them, there seems to be no reason for the talk to draw out this long. Why do you think it is taking half a day?” asked Javier.

“That, too, is simple.”

The corners of Lloyd’s lips pulled further up. “They are probably bargaining. I mean over things like how much liability the sultan will accept, the exact amount of compensation, and whatnot. Moreover, it reflects better on them to do this rather than cut the negotiation short.”

“Reflects better?” asked Javier.

“The sultan’s reputation. If the talk ends too soon, it will leave an impression to the people that the sultan GGed... No, that he easily surrendered,” explained Lloyd, correcting his words. “I wouldn’t be shocked if they’re sipping tea inside after they have already finished adjusting their agreement. That way, as the talk drags out, the sultan’s reputation will improve all the more to the public.”

“Is that so?” asked Javier.

“Yeah. So, as for us, we should just drink more of this.”

Lloyd spoke as he held up the expensive coconut.

“This is super expensive and all on the great and omnipotent sultan. One more thing, we can’t drink this even if we want to once we’re back home. You can ship it there, but I assure you, it’s not going to taste the same.”

“...”

“What are you doing? Come on now. Drink up!” Lloyd urged.

“...”

Taking the coconut Lloyd rashly held out, Javier let out a sigh. He sighed at length again when he saw Lloyd gulping on the coconut juice like a beggar who had gone hungry for months. This young master he served... Sure, the man was smart. But honestly, Javier was ashamed of him when he acted like this, being all materialistic.

Disliking Lloyd’s behaviors, Javier asked, “Can we not have an ordinary meal instead of something like this?”

“Eh?” asked Lloyd as he removed the straw from his mouth.

“It is time for a meal.”

“That’s why I ordered this.”

“...”

“They’re not giving us food today,” informed Lloyd. “I canceled everything and told them to only bring a bunch of this fruit.”

“Why did you do that?” asked Javier in annoyance.

“I told you. You can only drink this here. It’s super expensive.”

“Haah... Seriously...”

Javier could not help but sigh. Eventually, he spoke, giving up.

“Then I shall have only one since I cannot skip my meal.”

He was hungry, and it was time to eat. Though he didn’t particularly want it, Javier grabbed one coconut with the intent to put something in his stomach and have a taste for politeness' sake. Then he put his mouth to the straw and slurped. One sip. Two sips. Three sips. He slurped and slurped again. Before he knew it, the coconut was empty.

“Hey, you finished it in one chug.”

“...”

Lloyd giggled at him. It was only when Javier saw Lloyd’s face what he had done. But it was too late.

“You want one more?”

“...”

“No?” said Lloyd as he looked at the fruit. “Then I’ll have-”

“Give it to me, Master Lloyd.”

Thwack! Javier Asrahan, the historical hero of *The Knight of Blood and Iron*. He, too, helplessly was a young man in his 20s who couldn’t resist the taste of coke he experienced for the first time in the coconut juice in front of him.

***

The negotiation with the sultan and the envoy ended in the evening.

“It is done. We have succeeded at last.”

Count Ventura entered the reception hall, his face flushed red. The rest of the delegation jumped to their feet.

“How did it go, Your Excellency?” one of them asked.

“You are smiling. Does that mean...” another asked simultaneously.

“Yes, it is right.”

Count Ventura beamed as he turned around and faced everyone.

“The sultan accepted our demands. Every one of them.”

“All of them?”

“Is that true?!”

“Hahaha! Do you not trust me? As I said, it was a complete success. The sultan acknowledged that he is responsible for the Monster Domino incident. Not only that, he has agreed to all our terms for compensation. On top of that, he even offered to cooperate on one more term.”

“What do you mean by that, Your Excellency?”

Everyone’s ears jerked up. It was the same with Lloyd, who was tapping his belly filled with coconuts in the corner of the reception hall.

An additional term? The sultan agreed to it?

That was strange. He could have just accepted his responsibility for the incident and provided compensation. It was strange that he went out of his way to make an offer that the envoys didn’t even ask for.

Why would he do that?

Lloyd was curious, so he inched closer to hear the conversation better. Count Ventura continued to speak.

“Ahaha. Now, do not doubt a single thing I say here. The sultan has even signed an agreement that promises the prevention of incidents like the Monster Domino from reoccurring. Do you see what I mean? The sultan has willingly put aside his authority during the diplomatic negotiation and offered his genuine apology.”

“Oh, oh!” one of them cried out.

“Is that true?!”

The confident announcement of Count Ventura excited the entire members of the delegation. And it probably was the reason why Lloyd, who was observing the scene from a corner, suddenly felt his stomach flip over and the coconuts coming back up.

A prevention agreement? That man did what? He was generous enough to sign that? Hold on. Shoot. Could he be...

A bad feeling gripped Lloyd, sending chills down his spine. At that moment, Lloyd jumped to his feet and rushed off to his room so fast no one could stop him, and at lightning speed, started to pack to flee that very night.

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Chapter 199: A Cunning Man’s Survival Tactic (2)

Rustle! Crumple! Lloyd’s hands became busy as they chucked clothes, gloves, boots, and bandanas into his bag, as well as some food and a water container. He never spoke a word while he crammed his bag as though he didn’t have a minute to waste. In a ferocious and feverish manner, he engrossed himself in packing.

“What... are you doing?” asked one of the delegations who came over.

Lloyd looked up to catch a glimpse of the one who called him and replied, “As you can see, I’m packing.”

“Packing?” he asked further. “Packing for what?”

“It’s for when I run away tonight,” said Lloyd, pausing for a second.

“Run away...?”

“Yes.”

Rustle, rustle. Crumple, crumple. Lloyd resumed packing after giving his answer. Meanwhile, everyone who was laughing joyfully in the reception hall started to pay attention to Lloyd’s room, which was just adjoined in one corner of the hall.

“Why would you flee in the middle of the night? What do you mean, Lloyd?”

At last, Count Ventura walked over and asked.

Lloyd glanced at the count with a wry smile on his face. “It’s exactly as I said, Your Excellency. What else would I mean by running away?”

“Run away? Run away from here? Tonight?” asked the count again.

“Yes.”

“But why would you do that?”

“That’s because I found a need to do so just now,” answered Lloyd nonchalantly.

Even when he was answering, his hands kept moving. He packed rice oil to use against the desert sun and a blanket to get himself through the freezing night.

“Your Excellency,” Lloyd added, “didn’t you tell everyone earlier that the talk went much better than you expected?”

“I did.”

“That is why.” Lloyd continued to speak. “You said that the sultan admitted his responsibility for the Monster Domino incident, agreed to our demand for compensation, and willfully suggested and signed an agreement to prevent something like this from happening ever again, right?”

“Yes, as we already know,” agreed the count, still not getting Lloyd. “Is that a problem?”

“Yes. But only to me.”

A wry smile appeared on Lloyd again, who was still packing.

“The sultan isn’t a generous man. He’s not a fool anymore. Considering that, he must have an ulterior motive to agree with all our negotiation terms.”

“Wait... Are you saying that what the sultan wants has something to do with you?” asked Count Ventura.

“Yes. I know it’s hard to believe,” dismissed Lloyd.

“No, I believe you. Do elaborate.”

Count Ventura’s eyes grew serious. He now had complete trust in Lloyd’s competence. How else could he not? Without Lloyd, the negotiation

would’ve never happened. Their diplomatic success from today would’ve been unimaginable.

And now, these were the words coming from Lloyd, the man behind this stellar accomplishment. The count couldn’t thoughtlessly dismiss his concerns.

“I do not know about the others, but I will believe what you say. Please elaborate for me.”

“Yes, Your Excellency. Thank you for your words.” The wry smile on Lloyd’s face deepened. “This is purely a guess, but I think the sultan is trying to hold me down in this kingdom.”

“Hold you down?”

“That’s right, Your Excellency. The sultan wants me to be his son-in-law.”

“Huh…?” The count seemed unconvinced.

“It is the truth,” emphasized Lloyd, “The sultan already assigned one of his daughters as my guard when I traveled to the Kandahar region.”

“Is that so?” The count lifted his brow.

“It happened, Your Excellency. I said nothing about it because it was a personal matter and something not to disclose so publicly.”

“I see,” the count observed. “What you are saying is that the sultan has agreed to all our conditions because he wanted to make you his son-in-law?”

“I reckon he did.”

“But why?”

“To parade his generosity,” said Lloyd expressionlessly.

“Generosity, huh.”

“All of this,” defended Lloyd, “is my personal thoughts on the matter. The sultan must want to emphasize himself as a virtuous ruler with a big heart. If my guess is right-”

“What would happen?” interrupted the count.

“He will summon me to his palace as soon as the sun rises tomorrow.”

“Is it so he can show off his generosity and virtue to you?”

“Yes. and on top of that, he will try to assign me additional work.”

The count tilted his head for clarification at Lloyd’s words.

“Work? But what if you turn him down?”

“He will pressure me, threatening to overturn the results of today’s negotiation.”

Lloyd’s toneless answer caused the count’s mustache to twitch.

“Overturn the diplomatic agreement over one man? Are you suggesting that the sultan is that covetous of you?” The count’s voice dripped with doubt.

“Well, it is uncomfortable to say it out loud. I know it sounds highly implausible. But the more I think about it, I’m troubled as such an outrageous situation seems to be coming true.”

Now, the wry smile on Lloyd’s face couldn’t get any deeper. He was agitated as the ludicrous scenario in his head was turning into reality. And what was more agitating was that his speculation was aligned with what he saw during his time with the sultan so far.

That sultan was obsessive though he tried to act cool on the outside.

It was the same last night. Lloyd had visited the palace to report to the sultan about the construction of the Qanat, but the latter explicitly expressed his desire to have Lloyd. And now he did what? Unnecessarily decided to be extremely generous during their negotiation?

Perhaps. Maybe. A strong gut feeling that the sultan would summon and pressure Lloyd gripped him hard. He was afraid that the sultan would use their negotiations as blackmail. Take up the job I have for you! Or I'll break the deal once and for all. The fault is yours if that happens. Lloyd was afraid that the sultan would frame and accuse him of something completely outrageous. Should that happen, what could Lloyd possibly do?

I'll have no choice but to accept his terms. That will be the only way for the deal and peace to be maintained. I have to prevent my fiefdom from getting involved in a war.

Once he fell into the sultan's hands...

I'll be trapped. Would the sultan let me goal after one more project? That's a funny joke. He would never. I'll be assigned more work one after another. That's how he plans to trap me here.

If that happened, it was game over for him. He'd be stuck in this place, getting seduced by the sultan into being recruited. And give it a few years, he would fool himself that living in this place wasn't so bad. That was how he would end up.

I know this is a baseless hunch, but I always end up being right about these kinds of things.

His past experiences gave him a pretty good intuition, especially from when he lived in a room rental. There were times when he was slightly short on rent because his wage was pushed back. He could only pay a few days after his rent due date. When this happened, Lloyd's course of action was important.

I had to figure out the manager's movement patterns. I even had to sense whether the manager was near based on other people's changes in voice tones or behavior.

The case in point was when he headed to the communal bathroom at the end of the hallway or to the communal kitchen for some ramen. If he failed to catch on to people's gestures and bumped into the manager, he would be

scolded for not paying his rent. Then Lloyd had to plead with him to wait a few more days with the saddest expression he could muster. In short, his life experiences had sharpened his senses, and that tingly sense was on alert right now.

Ugh... I hate it.

Lloyd's shoulders trembled as he imagined a future where he was swept up in the sultan's artifice. Quickly shaking off his chills, he spoke.

"So, if the sultan plans on forcing his will on me, then I should respond in the same manner. That is, using the swiftest, simplest, and most efficient method."

"And that is why you are running away in the middle of the night?"

"Yes. After all, my job here is done anyway. Even if I'm wrong and the sultan doesn't look for me, I lose nothing from leaving tonight."

That was equally true. He lost nothing by rushing off. If he was correct, he was outwitting the sultan. If not, he lost nothing.

"As such, Your Excellency, please do me a favor," asked Lloyd.

Thump. Lloyd swiveled around now that he was done packing. Slinging his bag over his shoulder, he flashed a smile at the count, and the latter found himself nodding in spite of himself.

***

The next day, Count Ventura was sent to the palace first thing in the morning. Technically speaking, Lloyd was the one summoned, but the count went on Lloyd's behalf to entertain the sultan.

"Dear Count Ventura, why are you here when I called for someone else?"

The palace was tiled with sleek black marble. The sultan's voice was mixed with wonder and complaint at the same time. Count Ventura swallowed and thought to himself...

That young man from the Frontera family was correct about his prediction.

The count recalled what Lloyd had said the previous night, how the sultan would summon him to the palace the following morning. It appeared that his prediction was on point.

What a smart fellow he is.

A smile escaped the count, and he remembered what Lloyd requested before rushing off.

“The reason I arrived here in response to your order is simple, Your Majesty,” Count Ventura said.

“Simple? Do enlighten me, the head of the Magentano delegation.”

“Oh, yes, Your Majesty. Lloyd Frontera, the man whom you summoned this morning, is currently traveling back home,” politely announced the count.

“What…?”

The sultan paused. Count Ventura continued to speak.

“To be honest, Your Majesty, to everyone’s misfortune, Lloyd Frontera has contracted a serious disease. Judging that it is due to his prolonged stay in a foreign country, it was only right for him to be sent home ahead of everyone else.”

“You do not dare argue that he left to recover at home, are you?”

“Your Majesty, it is with regret to inform you that he was in urgent need of recuperation at home.”

“Do you possibly think that I will believe your excuse?” huffed the sultan.

“It is regretful to say-”

“Forget it. That is enough,” broke in the sultan as he swayed his hand. A bitter smile appeared on the sultan.

Lloyd Frontera. Did he see through my intentions?

It was regretful. He had agreed to most of the terms demanded by the Magentano delegation on purpose and meant to use it as a pretext to assign Lloyd to new projects. According to his plan, he was going to use the deal as blackmail if Lloyd rejected his proposal. The sultan meant to tie him down here under duress and make Lloyd his official.

He predicted my intentions simply by seeing the negotiation results. And he rushed off in the middle of the night using his health as an excuse?

What a sly and sneaky person he was! The sultan couldn't help but smile in bitterness the more he thought about it. At the same time, he raised his white flag and accepted defeat.

I lost. I was defeated. How could I bring back an official of another kingdom when he returned to recover from an illness?

The sultan could summon Lloyd back, but that would be overstepping his authority. He could also put a bounty on the man, but that would be detrimental to his public image. He would become a ruler who prevented a sick man from resting. And what if he went further and threatened to scrap the diplomatic agreement unless this sick man accepted more work? His plans would be made open to the world. Moreover, that would also trouble Lloyd at the same time because taking up his offer would be the same as announcing that Lloyd was against the Magentano kingdom. So, in short, it was risky for both him and Lloyd.

Ha.

Lloyd managed to sabotage his plan by vanishing in thin air during the night. He even made it so no one could gain anything from each other anymore. Lloyd designed a situation wherein no one needed each other.

This is exactly why I cannot stop coveting him.

Dumbfounded, the sultan finally burst into laughter and beckoned Count Ventura to leave. And all alone on the throne, he fell into deep thought

about the matter.

I will quietly let you go this time. But do not think you can avoid me forever.

Lloyd Frontera. I am going to make you mine one day. Whether I make you my son-in-law or bestow to you power equal to a prince, I will make use of your abilities to create a foundation that will advance the kingdom for a thousand years. The sultan resolved over and over again. But at this moment, there was something the sultan was completely oblivious of.

Everything became bleak and hazy as he burned with passion to recruit Lloyd. It was only the next day when he realized that his greatest talent had left his presence and set off on a long journey to meet Lloyd.

“What...? Sheherazade? She is gone?”

The girl with the most potential among his children. The daughter was set to become a sword master. The sultan clutched the back of his neck as he took the letter she left for him.

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Chapter 200: A Cunning Man’s Survival Tactic (3)

The following morning rolled around.

Whew. Goodbye to this place. Finally.

Count Ventura tearfully looked up at the sultan’s palace that had grown on him.

I never expected to stay this long.

It had been almost five months since he arrived here at the order of the queen. At the time, he thought he would negotiate with the sultan in no time. But he realized that wasn’t the case when he set foot on the land. Their reaction was poles apart from what he expected. He was intentionally ignored and deprived of proper treatment. What would have happened if Lloyd, the eldest son of the Frontera family, didn’t take the matter into his own hands?

We would still be far from getting into a negotiation.

His delegation would still be bearing the ongoing ignorance and mistreatment. The deal with the sultan would still be unimaginable. Otherwise, they might have had to return home empty-handed unlike now.

I am relieved. I am truly relieved.

The negotiation was a huge success. If they went back home now, they would be commended by the queen.

And it’s all thanks to Lloyd, that young fellow.

Was Lloyd able to slip out of Ahinsya unharmed? Had he succeeded in safely running away from the sultan last night? The count was anxious for a second. But a chuckle soon escaped him. Seeing that he hadn’t heard anything about the matter, it was safe to assume that Lloyd didn’t get captured, at least. Moreover, judging from the atmosphere of the palace,

something bigger must’ve happened than a member of a foreign delegation going missing.

“I heard something happened last night. Is that true?” asked the count expressionlessly.

“Yes, Your Excellency. It appears it is.” A senior envoy nodded. “There was a stir in the palace all morning. So, I quietly asked someone I was acquainted with.”

“What did your acquaintance say?” said the count, interested.

“One of the princesses has gone missing.”

“A daughter of the sultan has gone missing?” emitted the count, his eyes widening.

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“Was she kidnapped?”

“I do not think so. It seems...”

“That what?” hurried the count, disliking the man’s hesitation.

“She left the palace on her own,” finally finished the man.

“Ha...? Then she ran away from home?”

“That is right, Your Excellency.”

“Huh! Hahaha.”

Count Ventura burst into laughter. A princess who ran away from the sultan’s relentlessly secure palace?

That explains the unsettling mood here.

The count nodded. Truly, the sultan’s palace was different from usual. There was something unsettling about it even when the Magentano delegation was leaving the palace. The sultan didn’t even escort them out, let alone give them a grand farewell.

But it is fine since I did not expect either in the first place.

Plus, the disappearance of the sultan’s daughter had absolutely nothing to do with him and his delegation.

“Let us get going right away.”

Count Ventura led the delegation, leaving the palace at the modest farewell of officials of the palace. Soon, they were out of Ahinsya and took the path back home. Their journey was smooth and safe. They passed the same course of direction and city they used to travel to Ahinsya. Taking only the safest route in the desert, they finally crossed the border. And that night, they joined Lloyd and Javier, who were waiting for them near the border.

“Have you been waiting long?” queried the count, who was glad to see Lloyd.

“Ah, to be honest, yes, quite a bit.”

Lloyd, who was camping beneath the tent set up between the boulders in the wasteland some distance away from the border, shrugged and glanced around in happiness at Count Ventura and his delegation.

“You all safely made it out with no one dying at the hands of the sultan. I am very relieved,” stated Lloyd.

“Hahaha. Yes, that is a relief. You see, unlike someone else, we are not coveted by the sultan.”

“Hmm?” mused Lloyd as he narrowed his eyes. “Your words seem to carry a sting, Your Excellency.”

“How can it not?” said Count Ventura with a smile. “I am being nice now, considering how much you made me sweat...”

“Is that so, Your Excellency?”

“Yes, of course,” assured the count. “Even now, when I think about the sultan’s expression and gaze after he heard that you contracted a disease and returned home... Whew.”

“You must have had a hard time.”

“It was nothing compared to how you rushed off in the middle of the night with barely any preparations,” consoled Count Ventura. “How are you? I hope the trip wasn’t too difficult.”

“Thankfully, it wasn’t bad,” replied Lloyd with a shrug. Then he pointed at Javier with his chin. “It’s thanks to that fellow. The presence of a swordmaster is undeniably useful.”

It was true. The night he decided to leave Ahinsya, the best tool he had packed was Javier. The sword master. If anybody pursued and tried to capture him, Javier was capable of breaking through the siege and escaping by force. And what if he faced a monster in the desert or wilderness?

“That is a fearsome monster in the desert. However, it has become my lunch now.” Lloyd was happy to be able to mumble those words. What was more, the title “Top Gun from the West” he had earned recently was extremely effective.

I can’t experience dehydration under any circumstances. This is true within all desert surfaces and areas with an average annual temperature of 104 °F and above.

Lloyd was skeptical at first and wondered if it would work. However, as he traversed the desert, he soon realized that this was one of the best skills he would have gained, at the very least, for this place.

I wasn’t dehydrated even when I tap-danced under the scorching sun all day.

Javier, who was crossing the desert with Lloyd, didn’t hide his shock from him. Even a sword master like him was gradually getting tired. So, how was Master Lloyd perfectly fine? As Javier shot such a question, Lloyd smugly retorted back with a piece of advice.

“Dude, it’s all about willpower. Your willpower.”

Anyway, thanks to the title, rushing off in the middle of the night turned out to be unexpectedly easy. There wasn’t any problem while they were waiting for the delegation to arrive either.

“Anyway,” Lloyd went on, “I am truly glad to see you all safe and unharmed.”

“The feeling is mutual. Oh, and...”

Count Ventura smiled in satisfaction after pausing.

“I haven’t shown my appreciation for you until now. This comes late, but let me say it at this time. I truly thank you,” confessed the count.

“Oh, thank you, Your Excellency.”

“No, the gratitude is ours. I was wrong to regard you as materialistic at first.”

“Haha. But I am materialistic,” corrected Lloyd without any sense of shame in his voice.

At Lloyd’s banter, the count recoiled and shook his head. “No. You are not. You are our savior. Without you, the negotiation with the sultan would have been impossible. No one among us thought of splurging the Padashar to grab the sultan’s attention. Moreover, the construction you completed after signing a contract with the sultan, the...”

“You mean the Qanat?”

“Yes, the Qanat. I know that was what opened the negotiation table. If your construction wasn’t a success, we could have never even dreamed of

negotiating with the sultan.”

The count spoke from his heart. It was true. While Lloyd was gone to the Kandahar region for the Qanat construction, the count initially believed the talk would come through after some months of waiting. But as days passed, he found that wasn’t the case. One month. Two months. Four months. Through his stay in the palace, he was able to understand their intentions and realized that the palatial official’s mocking words to wait a minimum six months couldn’t be taken literally.

Six months? That would’ve been far from enough. I doubt there would’ve been an agreement even if we waited for six years.

The count was confident of it. The sultan had no intention of ever meeting them in the first place. He had despaired when he made this realization. He had cursed himself for his incompetence.

“I saw the prospect of us unable to fulfill the queen’s mission and the negotiation reaching a stalemate. I saw how we would return home without any good news, which would eventually lead to war and... countless young men perishing on the battlefield. My heart was torn in despair. But then you took action.”

Count Ventura gazed at Lloyd before continuing.

“All credit goes to you for the successful negotiation, preventing a war, and saving our young men’s lives.”

“Uh, um, I did it because I didn’t want my fiefdom to be forced into war-”

“That is the same thing,” concluded the count.

“Oh? Okay...”

Count Ventura spoke, emphasizing his words. Lloyd could sense from this that this gentleman had very little room for another person’s opinion. So, Lloyd was flabbergasted by what the count said next.

“I will report your achievement to Her Majesty in great detail when I return to the palace,” announced Count Ventura.

“Please... can you hold back on that...?” Lloyd begged.

“No, this is the only way I can return the favor I received from you.”

“...”

Lloyd sighed at length. I suppose I have another accomplishment under my belt. I hope I don’t get summoned before the queen for this. Lloyd wished direly to himself. Just like that, he joined the delegation and crossed the wilderness and eastern mountain range until he arrived at his home sweet home, the Frontera county. The count and countess welcomed Lloyd with open arms, and they showered him with words of concern.

“My... Are you all right?” queried the countess as she eyed Lloyd up and down.

“Oh, yes, I am.”

“How skinny you have become!” she gasped.

“Um, actually, I put on some weight because of how well I ate,” defended Lloyd. “Just a little.”

“No, no.” Countess Marbella shook her head. “Your cheeks have grown so hollow. What a disaster. Well, come on in. Let us eat first.”

“Um, I already ate while coming down from the range-”

“What do you want to eat?” she asked.

“Oh, wait for a second, are the defectors here? Led by Turtle Neck? His name is Termes-”

“Yes, he is here. Does duck sound good to you?” Countess Marbella wasn’t going to let Lloyd change the subject.

“Um... Then what about the pottery and silk? Have they arrived? I actually shipped some items to come here passing through Cremo. They should arrive at any time now, and-”

“I know nothing about pottery and silk, my dear. Beef sounds good for tonight,” she put in again.

“...”

And just like that, even before Lloyd could rest up from traveling, he had to dine by force. In between the feverish eating, he heard a piece of good news. Julian, his younger brother, graduated from his academy.

“Do not be surprised,” announced the count. “But Julian is second in his graduating class.”

“Really...?”

Lloyd’s eyes widened in genuine surprise at the dinner table when he heard the news the count shared with a beaming smile.

Wow!

Second place at the academy? That was definitely something.

Of course. What’s harder than getting into that academy is graduating there.

Lloyd’s mind flew back to the academy system briefly mentioned in *The Knight of Blood and Iron*. The academy was notorious for being difficult to graduate from. For example, only about 20 students managed to graduate in a class of 100 students. Moreover, graduation didn’t promise a bright future for them.

Among the graduates, only about the top ten percent are hired as officials in the royal palace. The other graduates need to take the employment exam and compete with ordinary people. But of course, the students receive more incentives than the others.

And here was Julian, graduating second in his class. This guaranteed direct employment in the palace. The South Korean equivalent would be placing second in the level five Public Officer Examination.

This fellow. It looks like he'll be working his head off for the queen.

Lloyd inwardly mourned for his brother because the queen wasn't the type to leave a talent alone. She was a frugal extortionist when it came to talents, and any capable individual was sucked dry for the kingdom. So Julian, who proved his intelligence by graduating second in his academy's class, would be forced to put his nose to the grindstone to the point that he'd suffer from chronic fatigue. But he would be happy to be exploited. After all, that was the reason why he earnestly studied until now.

Lloyd, who was thinking such, asked, "Then is that brat coming back home now?"

"Yes," replied the count. "He says he has time to spend time at home before he gets assigned. He wrote you a letter before he left the capital. Here, read it for yourself," the count said as he handed the letter.

Lloyd read it.

To Lloyd, I graduated, and I got fairly good grades. It's all thanks to you. I was able to give all of myself to my studies. I was able to give my all. And I realized a lot of things the last time I met you after a long while. It was all possible because of you. Thank you. See you soon. Julian, your young brother who wants to be your pride.

"..."

Lloyd carefully studied the letter. He was proud of every black word written on the white paper. It was only a few lines, but he swelled with happiness nonetheless. A part of him even felt an immense sense of contentment. Before he knew it, he had read over the letter five times already.

Graduation, huh.

Lloyd, too, wanted to graduate. He wanted to graduate, pass the exam, and land a job. But he was forced into this world before he saw the fruit of his efforts. Though he couldn't deny that the knowledge he had acquired in his world helped him a lot, a corner of his heart was occupied with a pang of sorrow for being unable to finish his degree.

Well, I know it's not like a diploma will feed me, but still.

South Korea was a tough society, and a piece of paper proving one's completion of studies didn't vouch for a life of success. It was the opposite. It was the ticket to enter the deathly, cut-throat competition. In some ways, it was more ruthless, aggressive, and brutal than this world with its spears and swords. That was what South Korea was like.

But still, I wanted to get a diploma.

Lloyd still felt regretful that he couldn't get one when he had put in great effort to get one. He occasionally pondered on the matter. And now, here came the news of Julian performing beyond any expectations of him and giving the credit to Lloyd. The boy even added a pleasing remark that he wished to become a proud young brother to Lloyd. Lloyd felt grateful and content as he read those words. His heart swelled with pride as though he was the one who had graduated.

That rascal.

I'm going to give him a noogie on his chestnut-like head. Lloyd carefully folded the letter thinking to make sure that it wouldn't get crumpled. Then he carefully put it in his inner pocket.

Later, even when he continued to have his meal and enjoyed reuniting with the count and countess, he had his hand placed on the middle of his chest. And as though the letter was responding to him inside, it rustled. Lloyd swelled with gratitude and joy once again every time it happened. The entire time he couldn't erase the smile off his face.

The count and countess were overwhelmed with happiness to see his son Lloyd being so joyful. They basked at the moment, realizing that their

eldest son, who used to be a troublemaker, had grown up to become a reliable pillar to their family. And their second diffident son grew up to work for the palace. But more than their achievements, they were happy that their kids grew up as faithful and healthy individuals. They grinned as though the whole world, no, the whole universe was theirs. So, the two were absolutely ignorant to the fact that an uninvited visitor, who had business with their eldest son, had arrived at the outskirts of the fiefdom.

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“Whew.”

At last, the tediously long journey has come to an end. And now, I simply have to meet Lloyd Frontera and record his amazing lullaby in my magic orb and go back home. Then I’ll be able to fall asleep again.

The dignified princess of the sultan kingdom. A high-level sword expert plagued by lullaby withdrawal symptoms. Sheherazade’s dark pearly eyes shone as they looked down at the Frontera county sitting at the foot of the eastern mountain range.

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Chapter 201: A Prison Called Lullaby (1)

“Bibeong!”

The booming alarm in the lake of the eastern mountain range echoed through the land. The morning began in the Frontera county at Bibeong’s voice. Lloyd’s eyes flew open as well.

“Haha.”

His bedroom came into view as soon as he opened them. It was not fancy like the annex hall in the royal palace or the reception hall of the sultan kingdom. But it was cozy and familiar. Lloyd dreadfully missed this bedroom during the last six months of his stay in the sultan’s kingdom.

“Master Lloyd, are you awake?”

As soon as he made the sound, a careful voice spoke from the other end of the door. It, too, was familiar, and he was glad to hear it.

“Yeah, come in.”

The door opened up slowly, and Emily, a maid, poked her head out and beamed at Lloyd.

“I brought you breakfast.”

“Thank you. Have you been waiting long?”

“No, just a little.”

“Oh no,” remarked Lloyd. “You must have waited for a long time.”

“No, I really didn’t wait for long. It is all right,” she hurriedly said.

Lloyd was even happy to smell the breakfast on the tray Emily brought. A light bean stew with shredded chicken, a wheat loaf of bread, two sausages, a soft-boiled egg, a chunk of goat cheese, and a cup of warm milk. It was a

modest breakfast for a noble. However, this was Lloyd’s favorite breakfast meal.

This is a buffet compared to my days in the room rental.

Lloyd didn’t like to have an overly fancy breakfast. It placed a burden on his stomach and heart. So, this was just enough.

“Thank you. It looks great,” thanked Lloyd with a smile.

“I’m glad, Young Master. I’ll come to take the dishes once you’re done eating.”

“Yeah.”

“Oh, right.”

Emily stopped when she was about to leave after putting down the tray. She turned Lloyd’s way and beamed at him again.

“It’s a relief that you got back safely.”

“Sure...”

Emily then scooted out of the room before Lloyd could reply. He stared for a moment at the door. Is this what being a popular kid felt like? This feeling of being welcomed by everyone. He didn’t dislike it. No, to be honest, he liked it.

That’s why I love it here.

A smile escaped from Lloyd. Just then, he was hit with a memory of when he first came here. As though he was a monster or an annoying pest, everyone he met gave him a cold gaze. Their gazes from them revealed their disdain and desire to avoid interaction and stay away from him. But now, those gazes changed into a warm, hearty welcome. And who did it? Lloyd himself.

I worked hard until now.

There wasn’t any grand reason behind their change of attitude. It was the fruit of his hard work and endeavor. So, from now on, he wanted to live the rest of his life tasting the sweet fruits of his blood, sweat, and tears.

I can do it.

He had solved countless issues during his time here. He paid off the county’s debt, prevented the Monster Domino effect, accommodated the refugees, prevented an epidemic, raised a generous amount of funds, and avoided war with the sultan kingdom.

All those issues were taken care of. By who? Me. So, it’s time to relax now. Farewell to my sickening days of work. I’m going to spend the rest of my life lazing around like a landlord. I just need to stay clear of the queen. I’ll have to think of a plan to make sure she won’t call me.

Lloyd lifted his fork with his new resolution. He then started to enjoy his modest breakfast, savoring his first day of retirement. In the morning, he went out for a stroll. The warm and bubbly sunlight of the early summer pleased him. On the way, he met a couple of welcoming faces. The rebels of the sultan kingdom, who defected and were now residents of the Frontera fiefdom. Termes and his rebel executives.

“I am glad that everyone arrived safely.”

They shared with him that they had come here about five days earlier and that they managed to safely cross the desert and secretly pass the border at the protection and guidance of Turtle Neck and others, even though the journey was slowed by their families. After that short chat, Lloyd’s first day in retirement continued to go by without a hitch. Whereas his morning was filled with wonderful people, his afternoon was filled with something even better, gift packages.

“What... is all this?”

About a little past lunchtime, dozens of carts trundled into the Frontera fiefdom, all of which were packed with large chests. The carts were so full

that it looked like their wheels would pop off. Count Frontera's jaw dropped at the sight. Just then...

"Mister Lloyd Frontera? Are you here?"

A man who was leading the cart in the very front yelled as he stood at the gate. Lloyd rushed at his calling.

"Here! On my way!"

Lloyd swiftly accepted the packages with great excitement. Once he signed the receipt, the workers immediately started to lower the chests off the carts.

"Lloyd, what is all this?" Count Frontera stuttered.

A satisfying smile hung on Lloyd's face. He answered, "My packages. No, the delivery of a valuable shipment."

"Shipment?"

"Yes."

Lloyd nodded and enumerated the items that made the count's ears twitch in disbelief.

"Pottery, silk, carpets, spices, and what else did I order? Anyway, they're all specialty products of Ahinsya, the capital of the sultan kingdom."

"Ahinsya's... specialty products?" stuttered the count.

"Yes."

"Who in the world sent these to us?" There was still a tremor in the count's voice.

"I did," said Lloyd proudly.

"Huh?"

“I sent them here while I was in Ahinsya.”

The smile on Lloyd’s face deepened, and he briefly narrated the story of how he splurged the sultan’s money.

“And so, I hired a cargo ship and commissioned these shipments.”

“To come here after passing through Port Cremo?”

“Yes. Come to think of it, I really made the right choice. I must have picked a good ship. I was worried that the goods wouldn’t arrive on time because of the long distance.”

“...”

Lloyd beamed nonchalantly at the count, who was too dumbstruck to speak. The mountain of shipments was filled with pottery, silk, and other specialty items from the east?

“Then, what do you want me to do?”

The count swallowed as he pulled himself together. Lloyd was quick to reply as though he had been waiting for the question.

“Please look for merchants in the capital, Cremo, Namaran, and other areas nearby. Of course, it doesn’t matter if we can’t sell everything at once.”

“You are right.”

The count nodded. He could see the impressive amount of products with just a glance. Could they all be sold at the same time? He thought it was unlikely.

It would be nice if one buyer could purchase all of this. But even a fairly large merchant won’t have enough money to buy everything.

Moreover, there was a limit to the demand for specialty goods, especially high-end ones. This meant that there was a fixed pool of consumers who

could purchase these products. And so, it was impossible to sell them all at once.

“I see what you mean. You can leave this job to your father.”

“Of course. However, it doesn’t matter if we slowly sell everything bit by bit, so please don’t overwork yourself.”

“Very well.”

The count nodded as he patted Lloyd on the shoulder. Lloyd could sense that the count was proud. A smile appeared on his face. He then received the items and asked the Skeleton Corps to stack them up in the storage. That took a whole day.

“Woah. I finally feel alive. Right?”

Lloyd asked behind as he walked out of the storage. Javier, who was silent for the whole day, was there. But strangely, he didn’t answer the question given to him.

“What’s wrong? Did something happen?”

“...”

There was something off about his facial expression. It was the face of a person who stepped on dog poop with their new, expensive shoes that still had their tag on. Javier’s gaze grew mischievous as he looked at Lloyd.

“Tsk. I can tell something happened. Am I right?”

“...”

“What is it?” demanded Lloyd. “Did I do something wrong again?”

“Yes.”

An answer finally. The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose up.

“I did something wrong? What is it this time?” Lloyd questioned with hands in the air.

“...”

“Seeing how you’re still silent, it looks like you’re really upset-”

“Master Lloyd, your lullaby. I did not know it was free.”

Under the yellowing dusk, Javier cocked his head to one side. Rough. And he glowered at Lloyd.

“I believed that your lullaby was an expensive service, considerably so.”

“What do you mean?”

“It is about the woman.” Javier finally got to the point.

“Sheherazade?” queried Lloyd.

“Yes.”

Javier nodded. His glare grew more ferocious.

“Recall the first day we arrived at Kandara. This is what you told me right after you sang a lullaby to Miss Sheherazade. That your lullaby is not free. That I am ignorant of how much you plan to rip her off.”

“Yes, I did,” Lloyd said matter-of-factly.

“Then what is this?”

“What is?”

“You did not make that woman pay for anything.” There was stifled anger in his voice.

“You think so?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes.”

As the two walked, Javier continued to speak bitterly.

“It can’t be that you’re simply counting the help you received from the rebels while she was asleep as her payment?”

“Of course not.”

“Then what did you receive from her?” Javier, walking briskly, demanded an answer.

“Her future.”

“What...?”

The nonchalant remark from Lloyd made Javier pause. Lloyd turned his way with a meaningful smile on his face.

“Let me say this once again. My lullaby? It’s expensive. I’m holding her future as security.”

“What do you mean...?”

Javier tilted his head in confusion, trying to make sense of what he had just heard.

“Do you possibly mean that she will sacrifice her future for your lullaby?” assumed Javier.

“Yeah, roughly.” Lloyd nodded his head. “She has amazing talent. You should know since you fought with her. Do you agree with me?”

“Yes.”

“More precisely, give me your feelings on her skills.”

“She can be a sword master in 20 years.”

“Yes, I think so too.”

Lloyd grinned. It was true. Javier’s judgment was correct, and it was how the novel had described Sheherazade. Her talent was on par with Queen Magentano, and she was set to become a sword master in 20 years.

But she fails to fully develop her talent.

The reason was simple. She died before that happened.

Cornered by the rebels, she fought to protect the sultan until the end. Hoping even in the last moment that her father would acknowledge her. She risked herself even when she could have retreated.

And so, she died in vain and never got the chance to reach her full potential. But now, the story had changed due to the Qanat Lloyd built.

The rebellion is not going to happen anymore. The Qanat solved the drought in the Kandahar region. People are no longer dissatisfied. So, the sultan won’t be surrounded by the rebels anymore, and Sheherazade won’t die protecting her father.

In short, Sheherazade would live. She would live a stable life until she became a sword master in 20 years.

“So.”

Lloyd spoke, his voice full of finality.

“There’s a person who will become a sword master within the next 20 years just across the border in a country that could potentially become our enemy one day. Moreover, she’s the daughter of the sultan. She might wield her sword toward us in the future. Do you think it’s right to leave her as she is?” demanded Lloyd.

“Um...”

“We have to make a move.”

“How?”

“We can bring her over to our side, or nip her potential in the bud if we can’t have her.”

Lloyd’s smile became slightly more vicious.

“Sure, right now, we’re on good terms with the sultan. But there’s no guarantee that will be true in ten or twenty years in the future. The sultan kingdom has the potential to be our enemy. That’s why I sang a lullaby for her every night while I was there.”

“You conditioned her...”

“Oh, did you realize that already?” said Lloyd as his brows lifted up.

“You did the same thing to me,” stated Javier.

“Yes, you are correct.”

Lloyd shrugged, then continued to speak.

“She listened to my lullaby for over four months. During that time, she was able to peacefully sleep at night. But now, my lullaby was suddenly taken away from her. She must be terribly flustered since she can’t sleep anymore.”

It was true. She was probably tormented by the abrupt return of her insomnia.

“She probably regrets ever learning about my lullaby. Why? She knows what she’s missing now. She’s discovered the comfort it brings. So, she can never go back. She’s changed from when she could overcome sleep deprivation with sheer will.”

“You... killed her willpower, which was a weapon that would defeat her sword master syndrome,” concluded Javier.

“Yeah.”

Lloyd nodded as if he was making a declaration. It was true. This principle could be applied to anything. It was hard to tolerate discomfort knowing it could be resolved. Once someone experienced what it was like to own a remote controller, they couldn't live without it when watching TV. A family could be happy with an electric fan until they felt the cool air of an air conditioner. There's no going back. The same was the case for furnaces, cars, elevators, the internet, and smartphones.

That'd be even more accurate in regard to sleep which directly affects the body.

Sheherazade, who was suffering from sword master syndrome, wouldn't be an exception. Previously, she would have endured the constant torture from her insomnia, thinking she had no other choice. She would have gradually increased her swordsmanship level through training amid such a handicap. However, she found out about Lloyd's lullaby and the tremendous comfort it offered.

"So, she can never go back," assured Lloyd. "She won't be able to forcefully push herself like she used to. I mean, she could come close using an extraordinary show of power, but that's going to take a very long time."

"Do you mean that we can expect a delay in her progress as a sword master?" asked Javier.

"Yeah. That's if she doesn't come here."

"Are you serious?"

"Uh-huh."

"Master Lloyd, you are..." Javier paused, holding back.

"Go on. You don't have to hold back," permitted Lloyd.

"..."

The corners of Lloyd's lips rose as he looked at Javier. It was probably his expression that prompted Javier to blurt out the worst insult he knew that

had been suppressed inside him until now.

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Chapter 202: A Prison Called Lullaby (2)

“Master Lloyd.”

“Yeah.”

“Master Lloyd, you... You are truly hardworking.”

“Hmm?”

Lloyd’s eyebrows twitched. Javier’s icy stare grew colder.

“But you are not just hardworking. You are also truly dutiful.”

“Hey?”

Lloyd cocked his head to the side, wondering what was up with Javier. He had given Javier permission to insult him. Javier wasn’t the type of guy to let go of this chance. Could it be that he was sick? In between Lloyd’s thinking, Javier continued to shower him with praise.

“Moreover, you are detailed. Always meticulous and dutiful in your preparation for the future. Not only that, but you also stick to your plan once it is decided.”

“Uh-huh, really?”

“Yes. I feel a sense of devotion watching you. Contrasting other haughty nobles, there is something comforting and familiar about you, especially when you’re covered in dust during construction,” smirked Javier.

“Comforting? Familiar?”

“Yes.”

“Like what?”

“Like a mole cricket,” said Javier with a big smirk on his face.

“...”

“The way you dig dirt so industriously, drill holes so faithfully and flatten the earth so meticulously reminds me of that insect. In particular, when I lay my eyes on your ugly and wiggly bottom as you struggle to shovel up the ground is the spitting image of a mole cricket. Not only that, your bottom smells just the same.”

“Hey, I don’t smell,” defied Lloyd to protect his honor.

“I suppose you do not know this,” continued Javier, not interested in Lloyd’s honor, “but mole crickets eject brown liquid from their bottom, a terribly stenchy one. Have you ever smelled it? The scent is reminiscent of a cross between dog poop and rotten grass, so it is extremely similar to how you like to hold a grudge against people even when things are well over.”

“Hey...” muttered Lloyd.

“What is wrong? Did you not permit me to insult you?”

“Yes, I did.”

“So, I did it. I poured my heart out.”

“You should’ve just broken one of my bones instead,” said Lloyd with a bitter smile on his face.

With a fiercer glare, Javier added, “This insult is kind considering what kind of evil you’re capable of.”

“Well, are you going to hate me more if I tell you that I had no choice?”

Javier didn’t say anything. He merely stared at Lloyd with a piercing gaze.

“Tsk. No need to glare at me so hard.”

“Should I come up with a worse insult?”

“No, spare me, please.”

Lloyd forced out a pained laugh. It appeared that Javier somewhat understood Lloyd didn’t hold any bad intentions. Unlike his sharp remarks, his likeability wasn’t dropping by even a single point.

Well, actually, it’s not like I did a horrible thing to Sheherazade.

It was true. Sure, he did intentionally put a brake on her talent development with his lullaby. He could also admit that it was an unfair method on his part. But from another perspective, Lloyd had saved her life.

She lived because I constructed the Qanat. That has to count for something.

Lloyd shrugged. The favor he bestowed on her was beyond unbelievable for Javier, Sheherazade herself. and so many others in this world.

After all, I changed her future. I changed her destiny of dying after being swept into a rebellion.

However, no one would know the future had changed. Lloyd didn’t particularly mind that.

I should be satisfied with saving someone’s life.

He didn’t need any gratitude. He didn’t even want it. He shackled her with his lullaby, so they were even. That thought granted him peace of mind.

“Anyway,” Lloyd said, “I am looking forward to how she’ll react.”

“React?”

“Her life was greatly affected by my lullaby. So, I expect one of two reactions.”

“One of the two, you say. What are they?”

“She will come to find me here or remain in her kingdom.”

“Wait, do you mean that she will visit here because she cannot forget your lullaby?”

“Yeah,” said Lloyd in regret, licking his lips. “But given that she is nowhere to be seen, it looks like she has chosen the latter.”

“She will overcome the situation by herself, I suppose.”

“Yeah.”

“So,” asked Javier, “are you sorry?”

“No, not really.”

Lloyd grinned. He wouldn’t lose anything because Sheherazade didn’t come here. It didn’t change the fact that she was going to have a massive uphill battle to overcome her sword master syndrome after discovering the comfort of his lullaby. That was going to postpone her from becoming a sword master by about ten years and thereby delay the sultan from gaining more power.

“So nothing to be sorry about,” said Lloyd, “But, you know, no one knows. She might unexpectedly appear right in front of us.”

“Master Lloyd, no way,” Javier remarked with a small gasp.

“Hey, did you already get what I’m trying to say? You’re smart. Your guess is right. The moment she sets foot here, she’s going to work as a piece of high-end construction equipment, I mean, personnel in the Civil Engineering Corps.”

“...”

“I already wrote the employment contract just in case. Very meticulously.”

“...”

Dear heavens, save this poor woman. Javier was speechless. He direly wanted to tell her to run away if she was near the Frontera fiefdom or would be met with the same fate as him. Javier frowned, feeling uncomfortable and uneasy, and saw Lloyd grin at him. Then the two walked side by side as the night wore on. The following morning, Javier’s fears turned into reality.

***

“Bibeong!”

Morning arrived in the Frontera fiefdom. The sun pushed out the fog that carpeted the mountain at night. Count Frontera stretched his shoulder amid the moist air.

“Whew.”

He was tired. It was unexpectedly harder to do something he wasn’t used to. But he couldn’t stop now when he had already started the job. Thinking so, he gripped the trowel and got moving again.

Stab. The earth cracked, and a chunk of weed was pulled out. Beads of sweat dripped along his forehead.

“Whew...”

His legs ached. He wasn’t used to squatting this way, and it was his first time tending to flowers. His knees were sore, and his shoulders were stiff. But he was able to power through upon recalling the promise he made to his wife.

“My, you are feverish. Are you catching a cold? Please don’t overwork yourself tomorrow.”

It was around when they went to bed the night before. The countess didn’t look well. At first, Arcos Frontera thought something bad had happened to her, so he put his hand on her forehead. It was hotter than usual. A mild fever. So, he told her to rest and relax lest her cold worsens. A look of agitation appeared on her face when she heard him.

“No, I can’t,” said the countess feebly.

“Why?”

“Too many weeds have grown in the flower garden. I need to pick them out as soon as I can.”

“But your health matters more than the garden certainly.”

“But...”

“Leave it to me then.”

“What?” Her voice grew a pitch higher.

“I can manage a few days. I will take care of your flower garden for now. Would that give you peace of mind?”

“Dear...”

One of his wife’s only hobbies was taking care of their flower garden at home. It was so precious to her that she didn’t leave the job to maids or servants in the house. There was so much gratitude in her eyes when she heard him talk. Her hands had warmly tightened as they held his hands.

Yes, I made a promise. So, I can’t get careless just because I’m tired.

It was a promise he made to none other than his wife. The world could end, but he had to keep it. He had to exterminate all of these weeds despite his sore knees and shoulders. With that determination, he then gripped the trowel. Along with his awkward trawling, the weeds started to disappear little by little. His mind cleared as he focused. Everything around him began to fade, including his sore knees and shoulders. Instead, his heart swelled with a sense of pride.

Come to think of it, I am truly a happy man.

He really was when he thought about it. The financial crisis that burdened the fiefdom was resolved. The countless number of refugees had settled down. His days were free from worry. And what of his sons?

Lloyd.

A smile of satisfaction appeared on his face as he thought about Lloyd, the ex-troublemaker. He couldn’t forget the time when Lloyd claimed he’d

build something called an “ondol” and make money. With a serious air around him, he had requested to borrow some soldiers to use as workers.

That kid, he’s still keeping his promise from then.

In return for his assistance, Lloyd said he’d give up drinking. The count didn’t believe him at first. The boy used to practically jump at the mention of alcohol, even when he was asleep. But, even now, he kept his promise. Not just that. Count Frontera had wondered if he was brought into this world to watch over Lloyd every time he saw how reliable and earnest his oldest son had become.

And Julian.

The same went for his second son. This one never troubled him very much. Always a faithful and wise son. But he had a streak of weakness. So, the count was somewhat concerned about how Julian would overcome this cruel world and how he would make a living when he wasn’t the family heir. There were times the count sighed to himself as the worry dominated his mind. But not anymore. He was ranked second in his academy when he graduated and was on a straight, clear path to becoming a high-level official.

I am... so happy, my sons.

In a blink of an eye, his two sons had grown to become healthy adults. They were ready to spread their wings and live their lives without needing his protection. That made him extremely proud, satisfied, and happy. His shoveling now reflected the strong emotions he felt. He smiled under the early summer sun. Just then, he heard an unexpected sound.

“Stop right there.”

“What business do you have here?”

The sound was coming from the main gate, and the voices belonged to the guards. Whom could it be so early in the morning? The main gate sat near where the count was, so all he had to do was stretch his neck up without

having to stand. But the roses that bloomed along the fence blocked his view. He could only see the backs of the guards. The visitor behind the closed gate was covered by roses.

Judging by how the guards are reacting, it does not appear they are talking with a local.

The fiefdom wasn't big. He knew all the people who lived just a couple blocks away. So; the guards' cold attitude only indicated that the visitor was either a refugee or a foreigner.

Oh, well, the guards will take care of it.

Count Frontera scoffed. He couldn't help it. It wasn't his job to entertain every random visitor that came by. Furthermore, he was doing something important right now. He was decorating his wife's precious flower garden. Not only that, he had gotten comfortable being squatted, and getting up or changing his position would make his legs hurt more.

And so, he kept digging with his trowel, remaining mindful of the conversation between the mysterious visitor and the guards.

"Excuse me, is this the Frontera estate?"

Count Frontera cocked his head when he heard the voice of the visitor. It looked like the visitor was a woman, and there was something different about her pronunciation and accent. Not from here. As the count thought so, the guards continued to entertain her.

"Yes, this is the Frontera estate. Please identify your place of origin, status, and purpose of your visit."

"Me?"

"Yes."

"I'm from the sultan kingdom in the east."

"From the sultan kingdom...?"

“Yes.”

“Th-then what is the purpose of your visit?”

“I come to meet the eldest son, Lloyd Frontera.”

“Young Master Lloyd?”

“Yes.”

Her voice was clear and confident. The count stopped his shoveling.

She’s here for Lloyd? From the sultan’s kingdom?

The count cocked his head. A woman from a neighboring kingdom. Here. To meet him. It was unusual for sure. He couldn’t just sit and watch as a spike of curiosity arose in him.

What business does she have with my son to travel all the way here for him?

At last, the count let go of the trowel and got up, supporting his soring knee with his hands. His view elevated as he moved. Over the rose bushes, he finally caught a glimpse of the visitor. Quite tall. Traditional clothes of the sultan’s kingdom. Light brown skin. Sharp nose and confident face. Dark pearly gaze.

“My name is Sheherazade from the sultan’s kingdom that sits in the east,” she divulged confidently. “To tell you about my purpose, I came to meet Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of this estate.”

“May I ask that you reveal your reason for meeting him?”

“Yes.”

The woman nodded. She drew breath to reveal the purpose of her visit. Count Frontera concentrated. At last, she went on in a confident voice.

“I can no longer go to sleep without him.”

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Chapter 203: A Prison Called Lullaby (3)

“Whew...”

Inside the reception room of the Frontera manor, Count Frontera sighed at length, but it didn’t necessarily lighten his heart. Acutely feeling so, he turned to the side and gave a look to his wife.

“What about Lloyd?”

“I called him.”

Countess Frontera answered him through her gaze. And their eyes toward each other slowly moved to the front, where a foreign woman was nonchalantly sitting across from the table.

“Whew...”

He sighed again at the sight of her. Count Frontera mused in agony on the possible things Lloyd did and went through in the sultan’s kingdom for the woman to say those words. And so, the count dearly wished for Lloyd to quickly return home and change this awkward atmosphere. Thankfully, his wish came true soon.

Knock knock knock. Someone knocked on the door. It was Lloyd. At last.

“You wanted to see me?”

“Come on in.”

Count Frontera jumped to his feet and personally opened the door himself, studying his son’s reaction.

“Eh?”

Lloyd stopped as he entered when he saw her. His eyes widened slightly. Count Frontera wondered if it was that of surprise. Or was it because of something else? But soon, the count was able to spot something while

observing Lloyd. He caught his son’s faint smile and the words he uttered to himself under his breath.

“I guess this is your final choice.”

“...”

Final? This choice? The count pondered what they could possibly mean. With a mildly anxious heart, he took his seat and asked Lloyd to do the same.

“Have a seat.”

“Yes.”

Lloyd sat on the sofa. But his seating choice was strange. He didn’t choose to sit beside the count or the woman. He sat in between them and looked from one side to the other.

“You must have called for me because of her, right?” wondered Lloyd aloud at the count.

“Yes... I did.”

A sense of relief soon came to the count when he saw how his son was barely shocked or flustered by the woman’s presence. Lloyd didn’t seem to have caused trouble in the sultan’s kingdom.

But I cannot relax just yet.

The count told himself that he knew nothing about what had happened yet. For that reason, he slowly opened his mouth to speak while trying his best not to hurt his son’s feelings.

“The thing is... Um... My dear Lloyd, can you honestly answer your old man’s question?”

“Yes. Of course,” assured Lloyd with an eased expression.

“Then, do you know this woman?”

“Yes, we know each other.”

“Then... did you, um, cause any trouble for her?”

“Trouble?” mused Lloyd. “I can’t say.”

Lloyd then chuckled. He was enjoying breakfast when he was called here out of the blue, but he wasn’t angry. He was rather happy. Sheherazade finally came to him, and now, he could tie the future sword master down to his fiefdom. Satisfaction swelled in him like a farmer staring at a well-ripe harvest. But there was one small thing that he was curious about.

“Did the woman say I caused any trouble for her?”

What could Sheherazade have possibly said? What did she say to make the count and countess fidget in their seats earlier?

She must have said something off.

Sheherazade was sitting calmly. But the count and the countess couldn’t stay still. It looked like they had a concern that was bothering them but couldn’t muster the courage to say it out loud.

Lloyd plastered on the smile of a dutiful son. Then in a reassuring voice, he said, “I think there is a misunderstanding here. Please tell me, and I will clear it out.”

“Hmm...”

The count and countess looked at each other and exchanged a troubled gaze. The latter nudged the count to speak, and he nodded with a look of reluctance. Lloyd thought that the count looked like he had taken a bullet for her. Just when he thought so, the count opened his mouth, his cheeks slightly red.

“Um, how should I say this…? You see, um, this lady here says...”

His face burned red.

“You see, um, she said she can no longer fall asleep without you.”

There. He said it out loud.

My goodness. How embarrassing this is...

Count Frontera lifted the teacup as he nibbled his lips. Countess Frontera held his hand tight and sent a gaze that seemed to say, “Good job, dear.” As for Lloyd...

“Oh, that’s true,” tonelessly admitted Lloyd.

Pfft!

The count spat out the tea, and Lloyd shrugged.

“It is true. She can no longer go to sleep without me. But she left out all the details, so it’s not what you think it is.”

Cough! Cough! “Meaning? What do you mean?” The count spluttered out.

Lloyd handed him a handkerchief and said, “She means my lullaby. You know, right? How I recite a lullaby to Sir Asrahan.”

“...”

They knew about the lullaby. Somewhat. The story of how Javier secretly had miserable insomnia until he was cured by Lloyd’s recital of vast knowledge was a secret shared only with the count and countess. Now that the coughing fit had subsided, the count pointed at Sheherazade.

“Wait, does she have...”

“Yes, something similar to what Sir Asrahan had,” clarified Lloyd.

“Is that why you sang a lullaby to her? Just like you did with Sir Asrahan?”

“Yes. Thanks to me, she was able to sleep soundly at night. But the insomnia must have crept back now that I returned home. Didn’t it?”

Lloyd’s question was directed to Sheherazade, who nodded after staying silent until now.

“You are right.”

The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose.

“Then that cheesy and creepy remark about how you can’t sleep without me at night must have been intentional.”

“Of course.”

Sheherazade nodded again and looked straight at Lloyd.

“I figured it was the quickest way to see you.”

Indeed. Sheherazade actually arrived at the Frontera fiefdom the day before. Her plan yesterday was extremely simple. Meet Lloyd as fast as possible and record his lullaby in her expensive magic orb.

I meant to return to Ahinsya straight away after achieving my goal.

Of course, that part, going back to Ahinsya, didn’t change even right now. Her sole focus was on the lullaby. She only needed to obtain that. It wasn’t a particularly difficult task either. She had a magical device that cost as much as a mansion but could record about 20 minutes of sound. And so, it could be used to record Lloyd reciting his lullaby. She only needed to set up a clandestine meeting with Lloyd. Away from everyone’s gaze, her visit would remain secret. It was simple. She would just quietly approach Lloyd to request a recording. However, it turned out she was wrong.

The reality was a bit different.

Sheherazade shook her head as she thought about the previous day. Right after she arrived, she realized that there was one big flaw in her plan.

Javier Asrahan. It was his fault.

That silver-haired knight had stuck to Lloyd all day! So, it was impossible to get close to Lloyd at all. And she couldn't think of a way to outwit the sword master's senses. Heck, the mere act of observing them was risky itself. As such, she scrapped her plan altogether and decided to approach Lloyd head-first. After racking her brain all night, she came to the manor during the early morning and let out an explosive remark that garnered everyone's attention. And here she was, finally meeting Lloyd face-to-face.

"Tsk, what a foul temper you have."

Lloyd's smile became wryer. He turned to the count and countess, who now seemed aware of their misunderstanding. There was a look of ease on their faces as they listened to his conversation.

"So," Lloyd asked Sheherazade, "I suppose you want my lullaby?"

"Yes."

"And you are not thinking of taking me back to your kingdom."

"Of course not."

Sheherazade put on a straight face and fished a plum-sized transparent orb from her pocket.

"This is a magical recording device. It can record about 20 minutes of sound."

"So, you plan on recording my lullaby, huh?" mused Lloyd.

"Yes." Sheherazade nodded and looking straight into Lloyd's eyes, she added, "I am not asking for much. Just 20 minutes. One lullaby is all I want."

"Really?" said Lloyd as he stroked his jaw.

"Yes."

“Hmm, but too bad.”

Lloyd grinned. He slyly cocked his head to the side and spoke.

“Nothing is free in the world.”

“...”

“Did you really think that I would hand over my lullaby for free? How naive of you.”

“But I came all the way here-”

“Come on. I didn’t call you here. Why does it matter to me how long it took you to come here?” huffed Lloyd.

“...”

Sheherazade was speechless. Lloyd made sense, sure. But she wanted to punch his face out of spite. That was when he brought something out of his pocket as he smiled even more nonchalantly. He opened the article up on the table.

“What is it?” asked Sheherazade.

“It’s an employment contract,” informed Lloyd.

“Excuse me?”

Sheherazade couldn’t believe her ears just now. She thought she heard it wrong at first. An employment contract? Why bring that out now? Regardless of her confusion, Lloyd sounded completely nonchalant as he continued to speak.

“I thought you wanted to record my lullaby.” queried Lloyd, almost teasingly. “Isn’t it to improve your sleep? That’s why you traveled this far. Right?”

“Yes, that’s right, but...”

An unsettling feeling swirled in her. She nodded, but her eyes were filled with distrust. Her uneasiness only continued to grow, and just then, Lloyd spitefully started to smile.

“Then you have to pay for it. So, please sign here.”

“...”

No way! She rolled her eyes down, her heart sinking, and studied the contract on the table. Words of despair crawled out of her mouth in spite of herself.

“Enlistment in the Civil Engineering Corps?Participate in various constructions for the Frontera fiefdom and work in compliance with the given regulations? Wait, are you saying I should do this?” asked Sheherazade, shell-shocked.

“Yes,” replied Lloyd matter-of-factly. He nodded and smiled as if she asked an obvious question. “Stay and work here for just five years.”

“...”

“Then I will record your lullaby.”

“...”

What the? Sheherazade gritted her teeth. To this, Lloyd lifted his brows.

“I know,” he went on, “who you are. But think about it. Do you think that you are being forced into something that doesn't suit you? You know that is terribly incorrect.”

“Wrong thinking? How?”

“It can’t be that you think you’re above shoveling and pickaxing, right?”

“Well, that’s...”

“Do you really think so?”

“...”

Sheherazade hurriedly clamped her mouth. Her heart sank. She had not given much thought about the matter. It hardly even crossed her mind. But now, she realized that she vaguely had those thoughts. The contract stated that the unit was mainly tasked with digging the ground for construction. And the suggestion to enlist in that unit meant she’d have to shovel and pickax at the worksite. And who was she? The princess of the sultan kingdom.

That’s ridiculous.

The mere suggestion itself was blatantly offensive and rude. But she couldn’t be forthright about it because of Lloyd’s strange manner of talking.

“Please think about it. Do you think shoveling is too low for you? Is it a job that’s only fit for peasants? You can’t be suggesting that this kind of physical labor should be looked down upon, right?”

“...”

“These are necessary jobs for our livelihoods,” Lloyd said proudly. “A construction cannot be done without a shovel. Without it, there are no paved roads or bridges that allow us to cross rivers. But that’s not all. That sword you hold, your jewels, and so many tools that you enjoy are produced using the minerals unearthed with a shovel and pickax.”

“...”

“Despite all of this, you can’t be saying that this job is beneath you. Right?”

“Of course-”

“Right?”

“No...”

At last, she agreed with Lloyd. All of his words made complete sense. She couldn’t find a way to refute him. But she wasn’t going to sign the contract

so easily.

“How about I pay for it instead?” suggested her.

“Excuse me?”

“Instead of signing the contract, I’ll give you money. A generous amount at that. What do you think?”

“I don’t need money,” rejected Lloyd coolly, not even batting an eye.

“...”

“My fiefdom has enough money now. The sultan gave us more than enough along with silk and pieces of pottery.”

“...”

“So, you should sign the contract.”

“...”

Sheherazade stared at the contract with a despairing gaze. In the end, there were two choices for her. Return home and live with insomnia. Or throw away her pride and sign a five-year work contract. She would have to carefully make her decision. Nibbling her lips, she hesitated. Lloyd chuckled.

“All right,” said Lloyd, sensing her hesitation. “It must be difficult to come up with an answer right now. I’ll give you some time to think.”

“You will let me do that?”

“Yes, stay here for a few days as our guest, and think it over.”

“...”

She welcomed the suggestion as she thought it was too cruel of Lloyd to ask for an immediate answer. So, she hurriedly nodded. That marked the

beginning of her contemplation. She pondered about it, absolutely engrossed with the choices in front of her, through her stay in the Frontera manor. Even when she ate decent meals, lay against the cushion of a VIP room, and strolled all day around in indecision, she grimaced, a frown never leaving her face.

And so, that must be how it happened. On the fifth day of her stay, she decided to take a stroll farther out as her heart felt heavy with frustration. She was sighing and walking along the solitary path in the woods outside the border of the fiefdom when she bumped into an unexpected figure.

“Eh...?”

The second son of Count Frontera. Sheherazade unexpectedly met Julian Frontera, who was coming back home.

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Chapter 204: The Unexpected Encounter (1)

Occasionally, there were moments when you were aware that you were in a dream. For example, moments like now when Lloyd was confronted with this unworldly yet vivid entity.

“Are you Lloyd Frontera?”

“...”

Lloyd blinked several times and lifted his head. Is this what it would feel like to talk with a burning Mount Everest? A fiery giant was standing in front of Lloyd. Its whole body was set ablaze with large flames, and from the despairing height near the clouds, it was glowering down at Lloyd with fire-filled eyes.

What kind of dream is this?

But since it’s a dream, I won’t at least die in the hands of that fiery giant, Lloyd told himself. As a sense of relief washed over him, Lloyd relaxed his shoulders.

“Yes, I am Lloyd,” he uttered coolly.

“Liar,” accused the fiery giant.

“...”

“Suho Kim. You thought I wouldn’t be able to see through you?”

“Oh, that’s...”

Lloyd was left speechless for a second. He wondered if the fiery giant was his conscience. Could that be the reason it was trying to take advantage of his guilt and push away the real Lloyd? But thankfully, this did not seem to be the case.

“I am the Master of Hellfire who sees through the core of all souls.” Hellkaros, the Watcher of the 19 Purgatories and the King of Hell, continued its introduction, its voice booming like thunder and rumbling like an earthquake.

“I am also the Master of Giolexius, the knight of hell you defeated.”

“Oh,” yelped Lloyd, “do you mean Hell’s Knight?”

“Indeed.”

Rumble...! Hellkaros, the King of Hell, stooped down like an inclined mountain peak. Lloyd lifted his head up, resisting his desire to flinch his shoulders in fright.

Looking straight at Hellkaros, Lloyd asked, “Is that why you came over to my dream?”

“Yes, you are right,” agreed Hellkaros.

“You’re not going to ask for compensation, are you? We were mutually at fault, and it was actually self-defense.”

“Self-defense...?” mused the King of Hell. “Mutually at fault?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded, and he started to explain in detail.

“Your knight and I were bent on ripping each other apart. So, the winner can’t be blamed for hurting the other. Do you not think so?” argued Lloyd proudly.

“Do you think I am here to quibble about who’s to blame?” scoffed the King of Hell.

“Then why did you come to see me?”

At Lloyd’s question, Hellkaros let out a snort of laughter, hot globs of fire spurting out of its mouth.

“To observe the qualities of a man suitable for Hell.”

“What?”

What nonsense was this now? Lloyd cocked his head, and the King of Hell continued to speak.

“From the moment you fought against Giolexius, I have been watching you. I noticed a quality of yours that sets you apart from the others,” announced Hellkaros.

“What quality is that?”

“You are petty,” the King of Hell began without a second of hesitation. “To an unimaginable level. You are as rancorous, cheap, and spiteful as a mosquito that sucks blood in the middle of the night only to hide from angry humans under their bed.”

“...”

Come on, no need to hurt me with your words! A spike of depression rose in Lloyd. Hell’s King, however, continued to diss him with its fake compliments.

“But more than that, you are careful like a rat who always plans out her escape. Moreover, you are so sly I want to set you as an example to other devils in Hell. There is also the singing. Your singing that drains anyone’s strength the moment they hear you and makes them wish their ears will stop working. That great singing that made even me, the King of Hell, regret living to hear it.”

“What’s wrong with my singing...?” Lloyd’s voice faltered.

“I wanted to play it on repeat 24 hours every day for thousands and thousands of years.”

“Why?”

“That would bring more painful agony to the souls that have fallen to Hell.”

“Wait a minute,” said Lloyd, shaking his head. “You don’t plan to broadcast me in Hell, right?”

“Why wouldn’t I?” The King of Hell shrugged.

“...”

“I am jealous of your talent and voice for singing. Moreover, on top of your singing, you are capable of mocking and persecuting the devils that oppose me. So, how does it sound? Lloyd, no, Suho Kim? How about you trust me and spread out your wings in Hell?”

Wings in Hell...! In Hell...! Hell...!

The thunderous words from Hell’s King rattled the whole space in Lloyd’s dream. It wasn’t a simple shout. Its voice reverberated deep within him, rattling the very core of his soul. Lloyd struggled not to get crushed by the violent sound waves and finally opened his eyes.

“...”

Chirp! Chirp! The early summer morning was filled with singing birds. The white curtain in one corner of Lloyd’s bedroom swayed. A ray of sunlight streamed out and scratched Lloyd on the cheek. He felt the warmth of the sun and thought to himself...

That was one weird dream.

To heck with the King of Hell. And it what? Wanted to broadcast his singing in Hell? That would make the evil souls further writhe in agony.

How frugal it is for a ruler of Hell to want to use me.

Scoff escaped Lloyd as he thought about the dream he had just had. The fact that it felt so real made him feel worse.

There’s no need for a silly dream to be so vivid.

Lloyd shuddered as he rose from his bed. The truth was, he couldn’t push aside the dream entirely. He still remembered the message that popped in front of him right after he took down Hell’s Knight. The following messages had undoubtedly appeared in front of his eyes then.

[The King of Hell is impressed by your tremendous accomplishment. The King of Hell has lost his corps commander but now has his eyes on your skill, tact, and potential.]

“...”

Tsk. Stop thinking. It’s a silly dream and nothing else. Even if the King of Hell is interested in me, there’s no way it’d chase after me for my singing. Lloyd assured himself that such a thing would never happen. Something like that was impossible in real life.

Lloyd loudly forced out a cough. “Hmm! Hmm! Ehem!”

Soon, someone reacted from the other side of the door.

“Master Lloyd, are you awake?”

“Yeah, come on in.”

Emily, beaming with a glow of satisfaction, entered with a tray of breakfast. She was the first to greet Lloyd on most mornings.

“You don’t have to ask, Young Master. I didn’t wait for long today as well,” Emily said preemptively.

“Ah, would you get mad if I told you I wasn’t planning to ask that?” asked Lloyd, his voice dripping with playfulness.

“That depends on how you act, Master Lloyd,” said Emily, amused.

“Understood,” said Lloyd. “I was going to aggressively question you.”

“Hehe. The soup is good today. Please try it.”

“Yes, thank you.”

Lloyd lifted the spoon and thought, to Hell with Hell! I’m going to enjoy this peace for the rest of my life. Resolving such, Lloyd enjoyed every bite of his soup.

Has it been five days now?

Sheherazade. The daughter of the sultan who traveled across the desert to acquire his lullaby. It had been five days since Lloyd demanded she enlist in the Engineering Corps in exchange to record him.

She should have reached a decision now.

Sheherazade seemed to be lost in thought for the past five days. Watching over her, Lloyd figured that she would make a decision soon and also that her choice wouldn’t hurt him regardless of what it was.

It’s obvious. If she chooses to enlist in the Corps, then I’ll have someone who possesses the talent of a sword master on my side. If she rejects my offer and goes back to the sultan’s kingdom, her progression to become a sword master will be significantly delayed.

Lloyd wouldn’t lose anything either way.

What will she decide then?

The soup had cooled to a perfect temperature. Finishing the remaining soup in one big gulp, Lloyd felt a rush of curiosity and anticipation at the same time.

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“Whew...”

How would she describe her feelings at the moment? Half dumbfounded and half dismayed. That was how Sheherazade defined her emotions. She

heaved a big sigh and looked up.

Chirp! Chirp! There were birds flying above the trail in the woods. In between them, she also noticed the clear sky and white clouds of early summer. What a truly beautiful place this is, she marveled to herself.

But staying in this foreign land for five years?

A sense of loss gripped her. *Must I go that far to obtain one recording? Must I invest five years of my life in it? And how would my father react if I made such a decision? He would go berserk.*

How could he not, considering who she was? The sultan's daughter. The princess of a powerful kingdom. Though, of course, she was the daughter of a concubine and not the queen, and though she was only one of the sultan's dozens of daughters, none of this lessened her princess status in any way. That was why she was frustrated.

How would His Majesty react if I spent five years working in a foreign kingdom's Engineering Corps after leaving Ahinsya without his permission… Whew, I can't even imagine it.

There would certainly be an outburst of chaos. But she couldn't even ascertain how bad it would be, and that was a bigger concern for her.

But I must become a sword master.

This was the most definite way to get acknowledged by her father. Once she became one, everything would change.

It seems worth a try if I consider my time here as an investment toward that goal.

She needed the lullaby. Without it, her insomnia would make her life hellish again and it'd become that much harder to focus on sword training. Her growth would be slowed, putting her far away from the path to becoming a sword master.

Bear my father's wrath and give up five years of my life, or safely go back to Ahinsya and tolerate insomnia? I suppose it boils down to these two choices.

Sheherazade let out another big sigh. Just then, she stopped dead in her tracks. She heard a sigh similar to hers just over a nearby bush.

"Haah..."

"..."

Whom could it be? She wondered to herself. This part of the path was quite remote from the Frontera fiefdom. She heard that residents and hunters didn't travel this far. That was why she decided to take a stroll here. It looked like a good place to have time for herself.

"..."

Sheherazade walked over in that direction and soon found the person who had sighed a moment ago.

A young boy? No, he doesn't look like a child.

Her gaze traveled over the bush, and there was a baby-faced man, whose height was only about 5'6. He had curly orange hair and round freckled cheeks. His eyes looked exceptionally smart but soft like a rabbit's. His short height and small figure made him look even more innocent.

Who is that?

Sheherazade narrowed her eyes. He looked suspicious. There wasn't anyone else except her this deep in the woods, and yet, here was a boy who looked like he could barely throw a punch. It didn't make sense. Furthermore, this boy was surrounded by a luxurious carriage and what seemed like his companion's luggage.

Hmm, what could have happened?

The stranger didn’t appear dangerous at first glance. The boy’s posture and gestures didn’t show any signs of swordsmanship. Just then...

“Master Julian!”

A man came sprinting from the other end, panting and out of breath. Collecting his raspy breath, the man stopped in front of the boy.

“Whew, ha... Have you been waiting for long?” The man breathed heavily in and out.

“No. I’m all right. What happened to the boulder?”

“About that, Young Master, I believe it will be difficult to get rid of it by today.”

The man shook his head as he wiped the sweat on his forehead. The boy, who was called “Julian,” looked dismayed.

“Really? That is a problem.”

“Please forgive us. We are trying our best to clear it out, but...”

“What if I join you?” volunteered Julian with a smile.

“Eh?! Absolutely not! Please do not say that. You do not have to do that for us. How could we dare ask for your help with this kind of work, Master Julian?”

“Um, I’m all right with it,” Julian said in a casual tone. “I would just have to roll my sleeves up, clear the soil, and push the boulder away.”

“T-that is exactly why this job is for us.”

“Is that so...?”

“Yes.”

The man nodded his head resolutely. Julian's shoulders dropped like a dog soaked in the rain.

"I still feel sorry," Julian went on with a contrite look on his face. "If I didn't graduate second in class at the academy, I wouldn't have received this carriage from the palace. We could have simply walked from here if it weren't for this carriage. That would have been less work for you all."

"Haah, not at all. Please do not speak that way." The man swayed his hands. "You graduated with honors, and we are honored and proud to serve someone like you. Moreover, this carriage is a precious one bestowed by the palace. It is also a token of honor given to those who graduate in second place."

"But still, it's just a carriage-"

"Please do not say that. We are really all right. It is tradition for graduates to return home riding a carriage bestowed by the palace if they were given one."

"But no one expected a sudden downpour to destroy the road," Julian argued feebly.

"But it wasn't you, Master Julian, who ruined the path. No need to be so critical of yourself. Sure, the ruined mountain path is muddy, and the boulder that blocked the road is quite sizable, but it is all right. We can clean it up in one day with a bit of effort."

Clapping in realization, Julian said, "How about we send someone to the fiefdom to tell them about this situation? They shouldn't have to go too far."

"That would be unnecessary," the man protested again. "Please think of our pride as well. We can take care of it. That is why we are escorting you."

"How about then I lend a hand-"

"Please wait here comfortably. There is no need to feel sorry for us."

The man grinned in satisfaction. He was covered from head to toe in mud. Despite that, he appeared to be genuinely happy to serve Julian. The conversation between the man and Julian left a strong impression on Sheherazade, who was observing them from a distance.

“...”

As she eavesdropped on their conversation, something came to her mind. During her stay in the manor, she overheard conversations between the maids and servants several times. They were about the second son, Lloyd’s brother. She heard he was quite clever, graduating second in his class at the royal academy. And so, he was set to proudly return home in a few days.

That boy, no, that guy, must be the second young master.

He looked much younger than she imagined him to be. And it seemed he had found himself in a pretty sticky situation.

Indeed, there was a big downpour two days ago.

It had been a while since there was a heavy downpour. And so, a portion of the road seemed to have collapsed in the rain. That was why the carriage from the palace couldn’t pass through.

This might be my chance.

Sheherazade racked her brain. The destroyed mountain path. The boulder was difficult to remove. Julian and the others, all of whom were stuck here because of this. What if she helped him out?

If I did, it would be easier to ask for a recording from that man, Lloyd Frontera. I’d be doing his brother a favor after all.

She would gain an advantage in their negotiation. So certainly, this was a clear opportunity for her.

All right. I will help him out.

Sheherazade weighed her options and rose from the bush and walked over to him conspicuously.

“Excuse me,” she called to Julian.

“Ahhh!” shrieked Julian as he jumped.

“...”

“Y-you got me really good there. Who are you?”

Sheherazade must have come forward too suddenly. Julian’s eyes went wide in sheer fright. Seeing him, Sheherazade thought to herself that the man looked like a fluffy baby bunny.

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Chapter 205: The Unexpected Encounter (2)

“Excuse me, will that be okay for you?”

Sheherazade swiveled at the worried voice. She looked at Julian’s eyes, which were one spot lower than her own.

“Stay back.”

A weakling who did nothing but play with pens in front of a desk. A uselessly adorable rascal. That was her impression of Julian from afar. Her feelings stayed the same when she first spoke to him later.

I plainly moved out from the bush, but he took notice of me much later and got frightened.

How pathetic, she mused. Had she held any ill intent, he would have been killed without having a chance to fight back. He behaved no differently from then on.

He let me walk all over him.

Panicked, he asked who she was, and she gave a genuine answer. My name is Sheherazade, and I’m a visitor from the sultan’s kingdom residing at the Frontera manor. I bumped into you while I was strolling here and overheard your conversation with your men. So, I’m planning to help you. She quickly voiced her objective without giving Julian any time to respond. Then pinning her gaze onto his eyes, she asked where the boulder was and said she would clear it out.

His reaction after that was more dumbfounding. He pointed to the boulder, his face looking absolutely blank.

How carelessly he behaved! Even when his men stood around in alarm, he didn’t care. Julian simply pointed to the obstructed path, his eyes wide like a surprised bunny.

Is he seriously related to Lloyd Frontera, that annoying manipulator? I find that suspicious.

A shiver ran down her shoulders. Lloyd Frontera. The mere thought of him made her feel frustrated. That was why she had expected Julian to be as annoying as Lloyd. But when they started to talk, she found Julian to be surprisingly boring and ignorant of the real world.

He's a young noble who's good at nothing but studying.

She looked straight into his eyes, thinking so. And she blurted in a monotone, "Farther."

"Oh, yes."

Julian scrambled a few steps back. The men around her shot her a wary look. They were covered up in mud from trying to move the boulder away. They were the ones who escorted Julian here and also knights who ranked as mid-level sword experts.

"..."

But she didn't think much of them. She only cared about moving the boulder for Julian and helping him. That would make acquiring the lullaby from Lloyd much easier. Thinking so, she turned and looked at the boulder.

"..."

It was oval in shape and huge. The shortest side seemed to be over 6.5 feet tall. The longer part seemed to reach over 13 feet tall. It completely blocked the mountain path, which was already narrow in the first place after having been constructed along the flank of a steep slope. The boulder seemed to have rolled off from the top of the hill and landed in the middle of this narrow path.

Whew.

Sheherazade took a deep breath in front of the boulder. With a scimitar in her hand, she sharpened her senses in a relaxed yet elaborate manner. She

glared at the target, searched for its weaknesses, and revealed her fangs.

Slash! Her scimitar emitted a deathly glow and slashed one side of the large boulder.

Crash! A fist-sized chunk was sliced off the tip of the boulder.

“...!”

Julian and the knights shot open their eyes in shock. But that was just the beginning.

Clang! Clang! Clang! Sharp, rhythmic sounds endlessly echoed in the air. The outline of Sheherazade’s body grew blurry amidst the glaring streaks of light coming from her sword. At the same time, the boulder started to grow thin near the top. More precisely, it was being cut down into fist-sized chunks.

Thwack! Crash! Crack! The process was similar to carving a sculpture piece by piece or slicing vegetables for fried rice.

“She looks... like she’s chopping a potato...”

One of the knights blankly murmured to himself, and everyone nodded in agreement. This spectacle naturally reminded them of cutting potatoes. Sheherazade’s swordsmanship and strength came as a sheer shock to everyone.

How is this possible?

Everyone was extremely curious. Only highly skilled swordsmen and women could slice through rocks with their swords. It was something only the best among high-level sword experts could succeed in. But slicing into a boulder several times in a row was impossible for even those sword experts. Why? Their swords were not durable enough to allow that.

It’s not surprising at all. In the end, swords are nothing but sharpened metal sticks.

So, striking down on a rock would obviously damage the weapon. It was unrealistic to wish for a sword to remain unharmed after smiting a rock when cutting a piece of leather or a chunk of meat was enough to damage its blade. That was the reason why a sword master's "aura" was considered the most powerful ability they possessed. The skill allowed them to slice through any object without harming their sword. But as for that woman...

She's not using an aura and isn't a sword How... how could her sword remain fine even when it hit the boulder dozens of times?

Everyone gawked at Sheherazade's back in shock and astonishment. Of course, they were ignorant of the fact that she was only one step away from becoming a sword master.

Hmph!

Her eyes grew calmer the more she wielded her scimitar. At the same time, her movements became more precise and focused. Every strike of her sword served a purpose. She used the minimum amount of mana needed to maintain her momentum while wielding the sword.

The moment her scimitar's blade met the surface of the boulder, she concentrated her mana in a flash and ramped up the sword's cutting force. This process was repeated throughout her stormy wielding, her focus never breaking at any point. Previously, it would have been impossible for her to possess this boundless ability to focus. However, it was made possible for her after going through a hellish training with Javier. But she wasn't aware of what she had achieved yet. Right now, she was only focused on the goal of getting rid of the boulder in front of her.

Smph! Spph!

Now, the boulder had been hit with over 200 sword strikes. At last, she gave her final blow when there were only 20 inches of the rock remaining.

Bam! The remaining boulder was neatly cut in half. Sheherazade took her scimitar away, blowing the edge of the blade that had grown hot from

friction. Then she put her sword back in its sheath as if nothing had happened and turned to everyone else.

“Will this do?”

She pointed back with her thumb where the boulder once stood. Now, it was only a pile of fist-sized, square rocks. No one, including Julian, could give an easy response. A smile came over Sheherazade’s face.

“Clean it up.”

With that, she coldly turned back. It was only then that the knights came to their senses and started to clean up the debris.

***

The night wore on, and it was like any other day. But not for Sheherazade. She was invited to dinner by Count Frontera for lending Julian a hand earlier in the afternoon.

“Without you, Miss Sheherazade, my youngest son would have been in a lot of trouble. Thank you.”

“Please do not mention it.”

The size of the table was modest for a count. Similarly, the food spread across the table was simple yet well-made. Count Frontera conveyed his gratitude to Sheherazade, and she shook her head and spoke.

“I simply came across a troubled man during my stroll by accident,” she said humbly.

“If someone else was there, they may not have made the same choice as you. Your kind heart and goodwill are what brought this fortunate meeting,” reasoned Count Frontera in a gentle voice.

“...”

His compliment made Sheherazade uncomfortable. Grabbing her fork, she thought to herself how she only helped Julian to get Lloyd's lullaby. So, why was everyone doing this to her?

They're making me uncomfortable.

Actually, she wasn't accustomed to compliments. Her subjects often praised her, sure, but it was rare for her to receive genuine words of compliment and gratitude from people of higher or equal status as her. And so, she felt uncomfortable at this dinner table as if she wore something that didn't fit her body. Furthermore, she couldn't get used to the unexpectedly sweet and heartwarming air around this family.

"My dear son, wasn't the journey too rough on you?" asked Marbella Frontera to Julian.

"Not at all," replied Julian with a smile. "I was treated very well by the knights who escorted me."

"Is that so? They sound like wonderful people," she commented with a genuine smile.

"Yes, Mother. Not only that, like I told you, Miss Sheherazade was of great assistance to us."

"Indeed. Thank you, Miss Sheherazade. Our family has received a great favor from you today." Countess Marbella's eyes were filled with gratitude as they fixed on Sheherazade.

"Oh, is that so..."

Marbella Frontera beamed at Sheherazade, who awkwardly bowed in response. Forking the salad without any words, she focused on the conversation at the table.

"Julian," Arcos Frontera chimed in.

"Yes, Father."

“It must have been hard for you to study alone in a foreign place.”

“Not at all,” replied Julian in a confident tone. “I had everything I needed during my stay there. It is all thanks to Father, Mother, and Lloyd.”

Count Frontera shook his head knowingly, however. “You may say that, but I understand how you really feel as your father. How can I not? I know how upsetting it is to live in a place full of strangers...”

Could it be that he was overwhelmed by his emotions? He suddenly chugged down three glasses of champagne.

“Father...? Are you all right?” Julian spoke with a worried look on his face.

“Haha. I am perfectly fine,” Count Frontera assured him. “I am just very happy. This day couldn’t get any better. How can I not be joyful?”

“Ahaha, y-you are right.”

“That is why.”

The alcohol suddenly made his face flush red, and his eyes became wet as they looked from Lloyd to Julian.

“I am happy,” went on Count Frontera, “that I am your father.”

“Father...” Julian’s voice trembled.

“In all honesty, I do not know how to express my feelings right now. I am proud of you both. There is nothing in this world I am more proud of than you two. Do you think it is because of your success? Since my oldest son is a reputable engineer and my youngest son graduated from the royal academy with honors? That is not it.”

The count tearfully continued to talk.

“I am not happy because you two are successful. I am merely thankful that you two grew up to be healthy and kind adults. I am grateful to be your

father even if I don’t deserve the spot. I want to thank fate for giving both of you as my son.”

“Um, Father, I think you are quite drunk-”

“No, I’m not. Julian and Lloyd… I am ready to give you the world even right now. If fate cruelly told me that I needed to roll around for the rest of my life to protect you both, I could roll back and forth thousands, tens of thousands, and billions of times with a smile on my face. If only that would make you two happy. Do you understand?”

“Yes... Father...” A shaft of embarrassment terrorized Julian as he answered.

The same went for Lloyd sitting at his side, and every cell in his body cringed at the count’s remarks. Countess Frontera, who was sitting across from the two, covered her flushed face with her hands, and her gesture seemed to say, “Why did you drink this much when you are a lightweight and when we have a guest?”

However, Sheherazade was inwardly shocked. Was she shocked because she, too, couldn’t take the heartfelt, toe-curling, and emotional speech from the count? No. It was the opposite. She was flooded with envy.

Is this... what family is supposed to be like?

She thought this kind of family only appeared in lofty and innocent fairy tales. She never expected to see one in real life.

This is... so different from mine.

Sheherazade clenched her fists under the table. Just then, the sultan came to her mind.

He was her father, but he was closer to being a merciless ruler. The life she had led so far to get acknowledged by the sultan! How desperately she had to push herself to get the slightest amount of acceptance, acknowledgment, and attention as she grew up among the dozens of princesses and princes!

Not a day went by when she didn’t use her sword. Even when the blisters in her hands burst over and over again and her father never bothered to look in her direction, she never let go of her sword. She lived with a firm conviction that her father would proudly accept and treat her as his daughter only if she became a skilled swordswoman and a sword master.

The same was true right now. The only reason she desperately wanted to acquire the lullaby from Lloyd and become a sword master was to get accepted by her father.

“...”

But this. There was something unfair about this. It turned out that getting accepted by your parents didn’t require you to put in back-breaking effort and soak your pillow in tears every night while comforting yourself that everything was fine.

Do other people not need to put in work to get accepted?

They didn’t. That was normal. That was what an ordinary family was like. Parents liked their children for no reason. That was how family and parent-child relationships worked. However, she never grew up in such a family and only had that realization just now. A pang of resentment and emptiness struck her heart. She felt like her years of struggle were all for nothing.

“...”

What am I? She clenched her fists under the table, shivering. She suddenly felt small. Her shoulders drooped, and her head hung low in meaninglessness.

From then onward, everything around her grew bleak. The food going into her mouth and the conversation she had with the Frontera family became a blur. She finished the meal in a daze and long forgot about striking a new deal with Lloyd, which was her original plan. Once she came back to her room, she sat blankly on the edge of her bed for a long time.

The night wore further on, and the moon and stars shimmered, ignorant of her feelings. As the white moonlight scratched the windowsill, Sheherazade rose as though she was allured by something and started to pack her things.

I’m going back.

She didn’t know why. She felt empty. The effort she put in until now. The acceptance she yearned for from her father. The sword master status she direly wished for. Everything felt meaningless and empty. Now, she didn’t want to think anymore. She wanted to rest for a bit.

I need to leave.

Creak. She slipped out of her room and entered the hallway, which was void of any light. The bleak darkness ahead strangely made her sigh.

“Whew...”

She couldn’t understand why she was sighing. Everything felt too empty and unbearable. She moved forward. With one, two steps, she trudged off to the end of the hallway. Tears started to run down her cheeks onto the floor. Right when she was about to wipe them off with her hand like an idiot...

“Miss Sheherazade...?”

Out of nowhere, Julian’s voice carefully caught her.

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Chapter 206: A Secret Plan to Stop Forced Labor (1)

“Miss Sheherazade?” Julian asked frightfully.

Julian was quietly sitting on a bench in the hallway because he couldn’t sleep. His home felt oddly unfamiliar for some reason. Also, all sorts of concerns pestered his thoughts. So he came to rest on the hallway bench, just to sit there. The summer night air flowing through the window opposite the bench pleased him, and the soft, distant whirring noise of insects tickled his ears. He stayed there with his eyes closed, feeling refreshed. That was when he heard something. There was a soft creaking from a door, followed by a soft thud of footsteps. And later, he met eyes with Sheherazade, who was looking around the dark hallway lest someone see her or she wakes the others up. Julian’s bunny-like eyes opened in surprise.

“Hmm? What is going on?” asked Julian in a daze.

Julian had blurted out the question in confusion. However, he wondered if it was a dumb one as Sheherazade was coldly staring at him with a leaden face.

“...”

But she didn’t say anything. She simply fixed her toneless eyes on him. Julian wondered if his silly question irritated her. Tensing his neck slightly, he quickly added, “Um, I’m sorry.”

“About... what?” asked Sheherazade at last.

“Excuse me?” Julian asked in surprise.

“What are you sorry about?”

“Oh...”

Sheherazade was still wearing a straight face. Julian was glad that she was now speaking, but he was taken aback by her question. Could it be that she

was really angry? But about what? And what was he apologizing for? Julian racked his brain to find a solution, but his clever mind, whose excellent performance as evidenced by his academic achievements, wasn't clicking at the moment for some reason. It grated and squeaked like an unoiled wheel.

"Just. I'm just sorry," Julian spoke after trying to think of a response. He gulped and looked up.

"..."

"For sitting down here, and um, catching you off-guard," added Julian as an afterthought.

Sheherazade didn't speak.

"If I really surprised you there, I apologize. I'm sorry."

"..."

Sheherazade considered her feelings. She was surprised but not angry. And she had nothing to feel sorry for this man and was quizzical about how she should respond to his behavior. Part of her felt flustered, too.

I never expected to bump into him here.

It never crossed her mind. She was too spaced out up until a moment ago and too emotionally drained. Even the sword master syndrome couldn't keep her attention laser-focused on everything. So, she didn't catch his presence.

"Um, hmm, actually, I was having a hard time falling asleep," Julian prattled. "So, I was just getting some fresh air. I never expected you to come out like this... and surprise me... Um, you know, I would have made some noise had I known."

"I knew you were here," tonelessly replied Sheherazade. "I wasn't surprised."

"Really...?"

“Yes.”

For some reason, she lied. Several times even. It was an odd and unsettling situation. This bunny-looking man had the power to make her lie.

“But what is that bag you are carrying-”

“Lunch box,” she immediately muttered.

Scheherazade suddenly felt a rush of heat, and her face burned red. She had given a half-hearted response to just get past the situation. But now that the words had come out of her mouth, she thought it sounded too strange.

Does he… see me as a lady who packs a lunchbox to go out in the middle of the night because she can’t get any sleep?

She hoped that wasn’t true. But this bunny-like man simply believed her outrageous answer.

“Oh, I see,” Julian accepted coolly.

No...

“You must have been very hungry.”

No, it’s not that...

“Actually, I was getting a little hungry myself, hehe.”

I’m not going to share! I mean, don’t believe what I said, she told herself. Julian was beaming so innocently at her that she grew solemn seeing him smile.

“Then I will excuse myself if you don’t have anything else to say.”

She quickly moved past Julian. That had been her plan at least, but she wasn’t able to.

“Um, I actually have something to say...”

“Excuse me...?”

Julian’s words stopped her dead in her tracks. She turned around and found Julian still flashing a smile at her.

“If you are going for a walk, then, shall we walk together?”

“Of course, I refuse-”

“I won’t ask you to share your food with me,” promised Julian.

“...”

“I actually have been wanting to go on a walk. But my vision is a bit poor at night because I’ve spent too much time reading books. So, I often trip over a jagged stone when I walk alone at night.”

“...”

“So, I will just follow you from behind.”

“...”

I should just lose him, she told herself. Sheherazade wordlessly turned around and walked down the hallway. She heard Julian’s footsteps following her. Not minding at all, she passed the main chamber, opened the door, and stepped out into the garden. The footsteps of Julian following behind her grew slightly more hurried. But she didn’t care, regardless. She simply strode across the garden, distanced herself from the annex, and stood in front of the wall.

“Wait, hold on-”

Jump! Ignoring Julian’s voice, she quickly crossed over the wall in one leap.

“...”

Now, he won’t follow me, she said to herself. Feeling relaxed and alone at the same time, she started to walk ahead. Just then...

“Argh...!”

Thump! Julian rolled and fell down to the ground from the wall she had just jumped over.

“Ugh, wait for me,” groaned Julian.

“...”

“This is so painful.” He dusted off his clothes.

“...”

“Do you plan on asking me whether I’m hurt?” he asked as he looked at Sheherazade.

“Not at all...”

Deciding to ignore him again, she was about to turn when an unexpected question stabbed through her heart.

“Are you still... in pain?”

“Excuse me?” Sheherazade broke off. It was he who hurt himself after clumsily jumping over the wall. So, why was he asking whether she was still in pain? Why was he, she wondered to herself, staring at her with eyes full of concern?

“You’ve been like this since earlier.”

Julian’s voice sounded like a whisper and continued to speak carefully.

“At dinner earlier… with my family.”

“...”

“You seemed to be in a lot of pain since then,” Julian said.

“...”

“So, um, actually... Here. Take this.”

Limping to his feet, Julian searched for something in the inner pocket of his vest that he wore over his pajamas and held it out to her. It was a vial.

“It’s digestive medicine. I figured you had an upset stomach... from all the greasy food at our dinner today…” Julian scratched his head. “Um, the medicine is quite effective. However, it’s extremely sour and bitter, so, um, I prepared this for you as well.”

He searched his pocket again, and this time, there were two round red pieces of candy wrapped in wax paper.

“It will be bearable if you suck on this candy right after taking the digestive medicine.”

“...”

Sheherazade stared at him dazedly, as well as the digestive medicine, the candy, and his hands.

He’s bleeding.

His hand was slightly scraped. Probably from the fall a little while ago. It must be quite painful, she thought. But his face didn’t show any signs of pain. He only continued staring at her with eyes full of guilt and concern.

“Pray, are you not a fan of strawberry-flavored candy?” wondered Julian aloud in a careful voice.

Sheherazade didn’t respond. She simply had her eyes pinned on Julian.

“Um, if it’s not that, then, I’m sorry for lying earlier. I honestly did have trouble sleeping and was idling around because of that, but, um, I was more

worried about you, Miss Sheherazade...” Julian trailed off, suddenly confessing.

“...”

“So,” he went on, this time more bravely, “I stayed in the annex hallway just in case as I was idling around anyway. I wanted to give you what I prepared if I heard you were awake. Um, and also...”

“Did you tell another lie?”

“Yes...”

His bunny eyes flinched. And with widened eyes, he spoke.

“When I said I wanted to go on a walk and my vision was poor at night...”

“Those were lies as well?”

“Yes...” confessed Julian.

“Was it just to give me this?”

“Mhm... Yes.”

“I see you are very good at making excuses.”

“I’m sorry...”

“It is all right,” she said. “I lied too.”

“Excuse me?”

His eyes grew round again. Sheherazade laughed for the first time that night at seeing his gaze looking up at her.

“I don’t have a lunch box with me,” she said.

“Oh...” he gaped.

“This bag isn’t a lunch box. It’s a travel bag.”

“Wait a minute,” Julian paused. “Are you leaving?”

“I am.”

“...”

“Are you not going to ask me why?”

“Yes, I won’t.” Julian shook his head, and with a gaze that had grown deeper, he looked up at her. “If I do, I might be forcing you to give me an answer. Then you would be reminded of the painful reasons you have, Miss Sheherazade.”

“...”

“I don’t want to do that. Now, take this. Here.”

“...”

The vial that contained the medicine. The wax-paper-wrapped candies. She took them in a daze, and soon, became struck with a thought.

“Hold on...”

She then opened a wax paper wrapper and tossed a piece of candy in her mouth. She opened another one and put it in Julian’s mouth. And she clasped the wax paper and rolled it up, grabbing his hand and pressing his palm with it.

“Ouch...!” Julian agonized.

“Hold on,” she said.

“Ugh, it stings.” Julian scowled.

“Stop pretending. You didn’t even know that you were hurt until now.”

“I didn’t know, yes, but it still stings when you press like that.”

“Stay still.”

Sheherazade couldn’t just leave him like this. The last thing she could do was stop this man’s hand from bleeding. That would lessen the guilt and regret inside of her heart. She pressed Julian’s hand against the paper harder. A look of dismay appeared on his face.

“Um, Miss Sheherazade?”

“Yes.”

“The candy. You shouldn’t have eaten it now.”

“…”

“The medicine is extremely sour and bitter, you see.”

“…”

That’s what he is worried about right now? It was probably because of this thought that she blurted out the following question by impulse.

“Why are you so worried about me?”

“Excuse me?” Julian gaped.

“I am asking why you have been so particularly worried about me since a while ago.”

She was curious and confused. She had to hear his answer to leave without any regrets. That was how strange Julian’s behavior was. He was like a baby bird worrying about its mother, nervously following Sheherazade everywhere she went. There had to be a special reason, she figured. So, she decided to find out. When she heard him speak, Sheherazade stopped breathing for a second.

“No reason.”

“...”

“There is no particular reason. Really, I am just worried,” replied Julian.

“...”

“I just idled around because I was worried about you and brought these for no particular reason... Since you are leaving, I now feel...”

“Sad?” she put in.

“Yes...” confessed Julian.

“Why?”

“I don’t have a reason for this either.”

“...”

No reason. He really had no special reason. Sheherazade bit her lips, tearing up. She had led a hard life until now. Up to this day, people needed a reason to care about her. At first, she couldn’t wrap her head around how Julian could worry for “no reason”. Then she was momentarily confused about how that was even possible. She wondered what those words meant and why they felt so foreign to her. And at last, as she found the answer to both questions, her suppressed resentment melted down the front she put on without a single trace.

“You see, I...”

From then onward, like she was bewitched by something, Sheherazade stopped holding back and expressionlessly shared her life story as though she was talking about someone else. She was still pressing his wounded hand. Her words were toneless, dry, and objective.

Her eyes started to get wet to her dismay. Nonetheless, Julian did nothing but occasionally give a silent nod. He never asked if she was okay or said she went through a lot. He simply met her eyes, quietly standing in front of her, and listened as the night passed by.

By the time the morning rolled around, Sheherazade realized at last that she had been keeping Julian up all night. Her desire to leave this place was now gone. There wasn't any particular reason. She just wanted to stay by Julian's side.

***

Ha! Look at those two. It's nice to be young.

Though it was early summer, the morning was hot, not warm. The season was harsh as it raised the hackles of a pure, innocent single man, Lloyd. With his chin propped against the wooden fence of the manor, he grumbled and gazed in the distance. A man and woman were walking along the pathway under the manor's hill. It was Julian and Sheherazade.

"Hmm."

Lloyd scowled, recalling the events of a few days ago. It was probably about five days ago. The night Julian returned home, gloom hung over Sheherazade's face as she joined their family dinner. It looked like she was about to dash off to her kingdom. But the next day, her face changed altogether.

It was the face of a completely different person. And she started to stick around Julian all day.

What could have happened that night? What could have taken place that explains this happy, romantic atmosphere around them? But Lloyd wasn't curious about it.

That isn't important.

Sure, he was a bit miserable about still being single. But there was something more important than his love life right now.

My retirement plan.

Not just any kind. It was a plan that would deal with the danger that he knew was coming to ruin his retirement.

Of course. If I sit idly like this, I'll never be able to live the life of Riley. The queen won't leave me alone. I'm sure of it.

Lloyd could vouch for it. Looking back, his accomplishments were too great. From solving the financial crisis in his fiefdom to managing physical, administrative, and pathological crises, he performed extraordinary feats that went well beyond everyone's expectations, eventually earning him the queen's complete trust. Lloyd bit his lips as he had the thought.

No. At this rate, I won't be able to live in peace for the remainder of my life. If I let things continue as is, I'll end up like Hwang Hee, the minister who passed away after being exploited by King Sejong for his entire life.

Lloyd didn't want that. He wanted to avoid that fate at all costs. He already did more than enough work up to this point. Now, he wanted to take a break and be promised a peaceful retirement. Thus, live the rest of his life leisurely and relaxing.

To do that, I need to come up with a plan.

Lloyd had a feeling he would need a plan before, but he couldn't think of one. He couldn't devise a good plan until he now saw Julian and Sheherazade happily flirting with each other like two lovebirds. That was when he was hit with the ingenious plan to ensure his beautiful, work-free retirement.

It's doable. As long as everything goes to plan, I can do it. I will be able to come up with a rough idea of how to prevent the queen from treating me like a slave.

Just then, a mischievous smile spilled out of him.

"Mwahaha. So, what I will do is..."

With a greasy smile on his face, Lloyd gazed down at those flirty birds in the path. And he reviewed the broad plan he just came up with.

"I'm going to be your cupid, Julian. Thanks."

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Chapter 207: A Secret Plan to Stop Forced Labor (2)

A long, long time ago, about 600 years ago, in the land of Joseon ruled by the Great King Sejong, there lived a minister named Hwang Hee. As a praised premier, he was very good at his job and King Sejong cherished him. Along with his favor, the king entrusted many responsibilities to Hwang, who broke his back every time he received more work. His broken back made him want to run away.

So one day, Minister Hwang pleaded to the king. Your Majesty, I wish to spend the rest of my life back home as my body has grown fragile. The merciful King Sejong thus said, “I shall send you my carriage, so come to the palace every morning riding that.” Sometime much later, Minister Hwang entreated the king. Please let me rest as my mother passed away. Please let me use my overdue vacation. Please put me in retirement. Please dismiss me from the palace. Please fire me.

But each time, King Sejong yelled, “No!” Because of that, the praised premier could retire only four months before the passing of King Sejong. What happened after that? He died before he was able to enjoy his life to the fullest. Ah, ah, what a happy, hellish ending!

This story may sound funny to some, but if I really think it through, it isn’t an unrealistic one… at least for me.

Lloyd replayed the story in his head and clenched his fists. Minister Hwang Hee desperately begged to retire. But King Sejong exploited and used every bit of his talent until he passed away. Someone could regard this as a slightly amusing story in the history of Korea. Lloyd thought the same before.

But now, the story wasn’t just an old tale to him. King Sejong and Minister Hwang Hee. Queen Magentano and himself. Unsettlingly, Lloyd felt that his life was dangerously flowing in the same direction as Hwang’s.

I’m not just being emotional.

Lloyd nibbled his lips. Actually, this was a feeling he had since a while ago. A swirl of nervousness sometimes rushed through him, waking him up in his sleep on occasion. He suffered from a nightmare where the queen summoned him to the kingdom and gave him endless work. When in fact, he planned to spend the rest of his life in peace now that he overcame all his challenges and obstacles.

But that nightmare could become reality if I let my guard down. That's the sense I get from the current state of things.

Lloyd licked his lips, his mouth feeling bitter. Ever since he joined the delegation to Ahinsya at the queen's command, a part of his mind started to whisper to him, "This isn't right." The same thing happened when he had gone to meet the queen with Termes to get the latter approved for asylum. That was when he felt confident about it. He'd certainly become the queen's slave or SVC if he did nothing like now.

So, I need a plan.

Lloyd had revealed too much of his capabilities. He had shown skills beyond what was necessary to overcome the financial, physical, and biological crises in his fiefdom, leading him to gain the queen's approval. But it turned out that the queen was the type to exploit talent and believed that the sufferings of competent individuals brought more comfort for the people and more prosperity to the kingdom. So, without a plan in hand, Lloyd would forever be doomed to work. He would have to say goodbye to the life of leisure he desired so badly.

That won't do.

Chills ran down his spine at the thought. He had already worked hard enough in South Korea. Even in this world, he had gone through all sorts of hardship. To him, the fate of working for the rest of his life was equal to capital punishment. That was exactly the reason why Lloyd felt the need for a plan that would save him from the queen's future exploitations. He had spent the past few days racking his brain for a way out.

And it's not like I can protest against her.

Queen Magentano was a ruler with absolute power. Her political power was unrivaled across the kingdom's history, and she was a high-level sword master. It was thanks to her that the kingdom enjoyed immense stability. Lloyd shook his head when his train of thought escalated to revolting against her because he wanted to laze around.

I'm not that desperate.

The chances of failure were high. Even if he succeeded, it would be the same as opening the gate of Hell, bringing more work to him. If he got unlucky, he could become the new king and be stuck handling government affairs for the rest of his life. Lloyd wanted to stay as far away as he could from that kind of situation.

Plus, Queen Magentano has complete trust in me. If I use this well, she could be my biggest supporter until death. So, it's better that she stays on the throne for as long as possible.

Queen Magentano's place on the throne had to remain secure. His goal was to relax and enjoy life under her stable rule. So, there was a need to solidify his footing in a new way, which would grant him a lot of rights without many responsibilities. A political position that would advantage him more than anything. That was what Lloyd had on his mind recently.

But the problem was that I couldn't come up with any ideas. Not until now, that is. Julian, it's all thanks to you.

The corners of Lloyd's lips curved upward. His gaze traveled to the pathway beneath the hill, where Julian and Sheherazade were walking together side by side. Sometimes one went ahead of the other to avoid the searing summer heat. Regardless, the air of awkwardness was still strong between them. The wheels in Lloyd's head started to turn at the sight, and finally, he found a plan to stop the queen from exploiting him.

Okay, it's doable. I think I can do it.

Lloyd saw a glimpse of hope. A chance for success. It was worth a try. Once he succeeded, the queen would have greater difficulty attempting to burden

him with more work. Heck, the atmosphere would even turn awkward, at least if she did try. At this point, a mischievous smile appeared on his face.

So, I think I should owe you something this time.

Now that he had a plan, it was better for Lloyd to get started right away instead of procrastinating. That night, Lloyd started to execute his plan to actualize his grand scheme. His first target was Julian.

***

“Whew...”

A helpless sigh came out of him. But Julian didn’t know why. He couldn’t understand why he kept sighing during dinner and why he didn’t enjoy eating at home after he finally returned.

I really don’t know.

Julian softly shook his head. His mind grew restless for some reason. Even during dinner while talking with his parents. Even when he was having grilled duck, his favorite. Something kept pestering his heart. His heart thumped without any reason, only to feel stifled. Then he would start smiling without meaning to. As a result, he couldn’t even tell what he was eating right now. To put it simply, he was...

“You feel like you’re going nuts, right?”

Flinch! It was right after he slipped out to the hallway after the meal, leaving his half-full plate and putting on an awkward smile at his worried parents. Julian shuddered at the voice that came from the side. He was surprised as he was just wondering whether he had lost it. It was like his thoughts were read aloud. Taken aback, Julian turned to the voice.

“Lloyd...?”

Lloyd was standing there, stroking his chin and glancing at him with a strange gaze.

“Wh-what are you saying? I’ve lost it?”

“I didn’t say you were,” denied Lloyd brazenly.

“What?”

“I was just asking whether you were having that thought about yourself,” clarified Lloyd in a matter-of-fact voice.

“Um...”

Lloyd’s nonchalant response put Julian at a loss for words.

“No, it’s not that,” hurried Julian, who suddenly felt exposed. “It’s really nothing. I’m fine. My stomach feels a bit unwell. That’s all.”

“Really?”

“Yeah,” swallowed Julian.

“Really?” Lloyd sent another meaningful gaze.

“Uh-huh.”

“Is it indigestion? Should I prick your finger?”

“Eh?”

Prick my finger? How?

Julian lifted his head and found an ever-so-suggestive smile on his brother’s face.

“It’s simple,” explained Lloyd, motioning his hands. “Tie your thumb with a thread and poke the area near the root of the nail in one stab! When dark blood starts to gush out, loosen the thread and rub your back. Works like a charm. Your stomach will feel much better.”

“...”

“Wanna try it out?” Lloyd waggled his brows.

“N-no, thanks.”

Stab his finger with a needle? Draw out dark blood? Julian instinctively shook his head, and he turned toward his room.

“I am fine,” refused Julian. “I don’t want that.”

“Really?”

“Yep,” said Julian, and he started to walk off.

But Lloyd continued to follow Julian. Why is Lloyd following me? I feel restless as it is and want to be alone, Julian told himself. But his brother continued to follow him, disregarding his feelings. What was more, Lloyd started to ramble again.

“Julian, I’m your brother. I know,” Lloyd remarked.

“Wh-what?”

“I know what you are thinking.”

“What... am I thinking?” muttered Julian.

“You feel like you’re in a strange mood, right?”

“Not really.”

Julian hurried his steps, but to his dismay, Lloyd walked faster to match his pace. To his greater dismay, Lloyd was able to directly pinpoint his inner thoughts.

“And yet, you don’t know why you’re feeling this way,” stated Lloyd.

“...”

It was true. He had been restless all evening. He couldn’t figure out why no matter how hard he thought. Helpless, he started to even feel worse. And here was Lloyd, speaking as though he could see through him. At last, Julian stopped and glanced up at Lloyd with a serious gaze.

“Lloyd,” he muttered hesitantly. “Actually, something has been bugging my mind.”

“Yeah, tell me,” Lloyd said.

“You’re right. I feel really strange.”

“Great,” Lloyd complimented. “Are you admitting your state of mind now? This is a great start. Should we walk more calmly?”

“Oh, yeah,” Julian replied to his older brother.

Lloyd had become so reliable unlike when he was a delinquent. His sweet and gentle voice. His face says, “I get you.” Julian completely lowered his guard, and he started to share the feelings in his heart as he strolled along the pathway in front of the manor with Lloyd.

“To be honest,” Julian began. “I’ve been feeling slightly off since this evening. But I can’t figure out why I’m like this.”

“You can’t?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Then let’s slow down for a second. Think back to late afternoon today. Tell me exactly when you started to feel weird.”

“When?”

“Yeah.”

“Hmm...” Julian started to think back. “Um... You see... I strolled with Miss Sheherazade in the afternoon.”

“Okay.”

“We talked a lot.”

“About what?”

“How she grew up. The difficulties she has with sword training. The reason behind the desert’s beauty. Stuff like that. It was nice listening to her. And...” Julian trailed off.

“And what?”

“...”

Julian paused. An epiphany struck him. He knew now.

“I think I’ve started to feel this way ever since I came back alone from the stroll with Miss Sheherazade.”

“Is that so?”

“Yeah.” Julian nodded, giving Lloyd more confirmation. “That’s right. I really think it is. Ever since then, I’ve been feeling restless, weird, and-”

“Empty,” Lloyd broke in. “Am I right?”

“Yeah. How did you know?”

Julian was amazed. He was amazed at how Lloyd was able to point out his feelings with perfect accuracy. As though he was begging for an answer, Julian gazed at Lloyd, who grinned. And Lloyd spoke as if the answer to his younger brother’s question was obvious.

“You’re experiencing your first love.”

“What...?”

“First love,” said Lloyd again. “Don’t you know what that is?”

“Um, I know what it is,” replied Julian curtly.

“Then good. That’s what you’re going through.”

“Me?” gaped Julian.

“Yeah.”

“First love,” said Julian again.

“Uh-huh.”

“With Miss Sheherazade?”

“Probably?”

“...”

Julian shut his mouth. The sheer shock of realizing his feelings made him freeze. He fell into a daze, looking back at himself to see if Lloyd was really right. He even stopped breathing and dryly swallowed. Lloyd chuckled as he looked at Julian.

I knew I was right.

Lloyd was right about what he saw. Julian and Sheherazade were strolling earlier this afternoon. He could see right through them. The two looked like a typical pair of lovebirds in the early stages of dating.

How could I not tell? I’ve seen this sight more times than I can count.

Lloyd was once a university student in South Korea. Though he was a civil engineering major where girls were thin on the ground, he saw many couples while walking around campus in the spring. Tons of them. His colleagues and friends often dated each other as well.

There were especially a lot of them during my freshman year.

Through the new student get-together, orientation, general assembly, and even blind dates, there were a number of couples that Lloyd saw come together in different ways. Sometimes, there were times he had to drink with a heartbroken friend whose situationship with a girl ended. And, of course, there was the time he himself had a thing with a girl.

Dammit. Had it not been for the coin karaoke.

Lloyd blamed the karaoke in front of the university gate. And he pettily hoped his friend would get athlete's foot for urging them to sing there.

Tsk.

Lloyd immediately suppressed his old memory, and he looked at Julian standing right in front of him.

Yeah, he's in a situationship for sure.

His radar, which was sharpened at his school campus, was right. Julian and Sheherazade had something going on, but it looked like the two were oblivious to their relationship. It made sense.

Of course. They're probably totally novices in this area.

Julian grew up doing nothing but studying. It wasn't much different for Sheherazade.

She likely dedicated her whole life to sword training until now.

Dating was a foreign concept to them as they engrossed themselves in the field of their expertise, that is until they experienced love for the first time. And now, they were set to have a rough path full of mistakes with little emotional intelligence.

But I can't leave them to break up. That would be a waste.

It was a waste for them both and for Lloyd himself. So, he decided to become a Cupid for them. Do a good deed that brings these two lovebirds together. And reap the best benefit of it. With such resolve in his mind,

Lloyd grinned with satisfaction. He then put on a confident face, gaze, and voice. And he started to make the comments he had come prepared.

“You’ll lose Miss Sheherazade if you keep fumbling like this.”

“What...?”

Lose her. Those words prompted Julian’s eyes to widen in surprise. Anxiety filled his eyes so evidently. That made Lloyd smile in a glow of satisfaction. Why? Lloyd was confident that his plan to make their marriage happen would elevate his status where he would be desirable and influential to both the queen and sultan and be able to masterfully two-time them. From then on, Lloyd licked his lips, ready to jump into action.

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Chapter 208: A Secret Plan to Stop Forced Labor (3)

First love. Much like measles, it was an emotion that blossomed inside everyone at least once in their life. It was also a painful memory for most because they were too clumsy to clutch and reap its final fruits. Lloyd, too, had experienced his first love. Back in his days when stores rented out books, his heart used to pound every time he looked at the part-time worker there. He was confused as to what was happening to him, why his face kept getting red. A clench of dismay rushed through him as he couldn't make sense of his bodily reactions. But strangely and too much of his dismay, he found himself making for the store on his own all the time, each visit causing the same terrible blush on his face and the maddening increase of heartbeat. Even so, he mysteriously ushered himself to the store, as if drawn by something enchanting, and borrowed piles of books he wouldn't read. The reason behind his strange behavior was clarified only much later when the girl quit her job.

Tsk.

Lloyd knew neither her phone number nor her name. They never properly spoke. Just like that, his first love at 14 ended in failure. Lloyd pushed aside his old memory and spoke, looking straight into Julian's eyes.

"You'll lose Miss Sheherazade if you keep fumbling like this."

"What...?"

Julian's eyes widened like a bunny's.

"I'm not joking," Lloyd continued. "You do know why she crossed the desert to come here, right?"

"Oh, I do," Julian replied. "She told me she has something to get from you. That she wants to record your lullaby..."

"What do you think will happen if I give her a recording right now?" Lloyd glanced at him meaningfully.

“Lloyd...?”

“Then she will go back to her kingdom, right?”

“Oh, I... guess?” Julian’s voice trembled.

“What are you going to do about it?” echoed Lloyd heavily.

Now, Lloyd could hear the wheels in Julian’s head turning. His eyes shook when he resumed. “Um, Lloyd, are you really going to do that?”

His gaze seemed to beg, “Please don’t!”

“I don’t know,” Lloyd said in a dry tone. “The decision isn’t mine to make.”

“Then?”

“It’s up to Miss Sheherazade.”

His tone started to sound more nonchalant, as though he knew nothing and didn’t care what decision she made.

“The thing is,” Lloyd continued, “I laid out the choices she had a few days before you arrived. It was either to serve in the Engineering Corps for five years in exchange for the lullaby recording or go back.”

“Then...” Julian mumbled, unsure how to react.

“If she thankfully takes my offer, she will spend about five years here. If not, well, there’s nothing I can do.” Lloyd stressed his last words.

“Th-that’s-”

“You don’t want that to happen, right?” exclaimed Lloyd.

Nod. Julian nodded his head earnestly. Done. I succeeded in coaxing him, Lloyd told himself as he put on a smile that only he would know the reason behind.

“I know, you must hate to see her leave,” cooed Lloyd. “You want to always be with her. But you don’t know what to do about it. Right?”

“Yes...” Julian said, looking up at him with a more desperate gaze. “Lloyd, what should I do?”

“What you should do?”

“Yeah.”

“First, I suggest you observe her feelings.”

“Her feelings?”

“Yeah, this matter involves more than just how you feel.”

It was true. You couldn’t just think about your own feelings. It was important to consider if the object of your affection liked you too. So, Julian had to be considerate of the other party and learn about her feelings as carefully as possible.

That’s what I heard. From who? A classmate of mine.

The thing was, Lloyd never had a girlfriend before. He had never had any experience in that field. Though he was sad that was the case, it hardly mattered right now.

It doesn’t matter even if I don’t have any experience in this. What matters now is helping Julian realize his feelings and coaxing him to take action.

He just needed to gently coax him. And then what? Everything would naturally move forward after that.

Sheherazade must be feeling similar to Julian.

Thinking so, Lloyd tapped Julian’s shoulders.

“It’s nothing too difficult,” Lloyd comforted.“Now, you know what you’re feeling. So, stay true to your heart and take action. Be nicer to her, and

when you find a chance, how about showing some courage?”

“Showing some courage?” gasped Julian.

“Uh-huh.”

“Do you mean to tell her how I feel?” gasped Julian again.

“Of course.”

Gulp. Julian’s neck bobbed as he swallowed. The mere thought of the act made him nervous. But then, Lloyd saw in a split second the vague light of determination flashing across Julian’s eyes.

That rascal.

Lloyd desperately suppressed his laughter, swallowing hard. He figured he could leave it here with Julian. Now, it was time to gently coax Sheherazade.

***

“Mwahaha.”

“...”

“Mwahahaha.”

“...”

The next morning, Javier seriously questioned whether his young master was in the right state of mind.

What is happening?

Javier stared at the back of Lloyd’s chestnut-shaped head with a leery gaze. They were taking a morning stroll after eating breakfast, and the man walking ahead of him kept letting out eerie bursts of laughter for some reason.

“Mwahahahaha.”

“...”

At last, unable to hold back any longer, Javier decided to ask. “What are you so happy about?”

Javier’s experiences told him that Lloyd was laughing like that for a reason. Convinced that Lloyd must be brewing up something treacherous, he asked him a question. And just as Javier expected, Lloyd stopped and turned, batting back with a peculiar smile on his face.

“Do I look like I am in your eyes as well?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Do I look happy?”

“Yes.”

“You saw it right,” admitted Lloyd. “I am happy.” And he added, “I think my plan will go very well.”

“Your plan?” asked Javier.

“A man and woman with different backgrounds, paths, and purposes in life will finally become one.”

“Could it be,” Javier mused, “that you are referring to Master Julian and Miss Sheherazade?”

“Hm? How did you know that?” Lloyd raised his brows.

“It would be impossible for me not to know,” Javier said matter-of-factly. “There was something special in their gaze toward each other. It is a look I have seen countless times.”

“You? You’ve seen this look countless times?” said Lloyd with a frown.

“Yes.”

“How?”

“It was very similar to the gaze I receive from women before they hand me a love letter,” Javier said expressionlessly.

“...”

“To give the exact number of times I have received this gaze-”

“Don’t count.”

“860-”

“I said don’t count.”

“...”

Lloyd felt a distinct wave of envy surging in his heart each time he met someone handsome. He was jealous about how they enjoyed so many perks just because they were good-looking. But Lloyd, with a bit of struggle, decided to pull himself together.

“Tsk. Anyway, you were right. It looks like the two will confirm their feelings for each other soon,” huffed Lloyd.

“How?”

“What do you mean ‘how’? I pushed them.”

“You, Master Lloyd?” asked Javier in disbelief.

“Uh-huh.”

Lloyd nodded his head. And he recalled what he had done the previous night.

“I went up to Julian,” narrated Lloyd. “I probed him a little to test the water. And just like I predicted, Julian was completely oblivious to his feelings.”

“Is that why you told him?”

“Yeah, and I did the same to Sheherazade,” divulged Lloyd with a smile.

Yes, he did. Right after encouraging Julian, Lloyd visited Sheherazade, who, at first, raised her guard when the former tried to strike up a conversation. Her attitude was nothing surprising. After all, she had been tricked by Lloyd multiple times already ever since they were Ahinsya. And she was unexpectedly coerced with an employment contract after traveling all the way across the desert to come here.

“She seemed determined to not believe anything I say,” Lloyd recalled.

“But how did you-”

“How did I make her come around?” stated Lloyd.

“Yes.”

Putting a big smile, Lloyd replied, “Well, nothing much. I told her that Julian would leave for the palace soon.”

That was true. All Lloyd needed to do was make them feel more anxious to stay together. And if he had solid evidence to back his claim, his words would become much more impactful. That was the very method Lloyd used against Sheherazade.

“I told her the plain truth,” added Lloyd. “I told her that Julian graduated second in his class, and he’ll soon be assigned a position in the palace. And he’s waiting here at home before he gets his assignment.”

Every word that came out of his mouth was true. Julian was set to return to the capital soon, and he’d become a resident of the capital as a palace official. So obviously, there was no reason for him to stay here, which meant he would grow distant from Sheherazade.

“I threw out a crucial fact that would make her turn toward Julian again. You know, people are always like that. They don’t take any action until they realize that there’s a time limit. That’s when they get all nervous and obsessive.”

It really was true. Even the things people took for granted evolved into something valuable when there was a time limit. For example, this could be seen during a 24-hour sale. A pack of ramen that someone normally didn’t eat would become a necessary purchase if it had a 50% discount for the day. That was the case even with products people didn’t plan to buy. The fear of regret made them eventually justify that they’d want the ramen sometime later and that purchasing it on sale was a smart move.

The same goes for cars. In particular, foreign cars. Sometimes, dealers will spread a rumor during their end-of-year sales that a specific model will be out of production starting next year. And a whole pack of people who’ve always wanted to buy the model but hesitated to flood to the dealer because they don’t want to miss their chance to own one. But come next year, the rumor turns out to be nonsense. They sell the same car all year long without a halt.

This sales method, “Now or Never,” stimulated people’s minds, and what Lloyd did to Sheherazade was similar.

“I told her Julian would stay here for a limited time. Now, she’ll start to think that she doesn’t want to lose him. Then this will naturally lead her to wonder why she’s having that thought.”

“Do you mean that she will realize her feelings in the process?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, I like that you’re a fast thinker,” Lloyd uttered, raising one of his brows.

“And I do not like this side of you, Master Lloyd” Javier’s face straightened. “I wish to ask your reason behind pairing them together. Your intentions can’t be pure, can it?”

“Mhm, of course not.”

Lloyd’s lips curved up, but his smile wasn’t innocent of course.

“I am doing this because I don’t want the queen to walk all over me.”

“Excuse me?”

Javier cocked his head to the side, unable to understand what he was talking about. What does pairing together Master Julian and Miss Sheherazade have anything to do with the queen? Javier felt a flood of curiosity surging in him.

“When the two get married,” Lloyd explained with a wry smile, “the queen won’t be able to treat me like a slave. No, even if it doesn’t go the way I want to, at least the grounds for my ultimate goal will be set.”

“May I ask how?”

“Sure thing. Simply put, when Julian and Sheherazade get married, my family will closely be allied with both the Magentano Royalty and the sultan’s kingdom.”

“Is that not treason?” Javier asked seriously.

“Not at all,” noted Lloyd. “Julian isn’t the eldest in the family. He’s the second son, so he won’t inherit the family estate. Thus, there’s nothing wrong with him marrying the princess of a sultan. Actually, it’s something to welcome at this moment in time.”

“What is that?”

“We just signed the peace treaty with the sultan.” There was confidence in Lloyd’s voice. “The sultan unexpectedly accepted his responsibility for the Monster Domino phenomenon. He paid a hefty compensation and even signed a safeguard agreement. As a result, these two arch-nemeses entered a period of peace.”

“Then,” Javier contributed, “if the second son of the Frontera county, which served as the hub of reconstruction after the Monster Domino tragedy, marries the princess of the sultan, who accepted responsibility for the incident, amid this peaceful era...”

“Their marriage will bring a promise of peace for everyone,” Lloyd finished. “For the royals, the public, and everyone else.”

In other words, their marriage would become an icon of peace. Furthermore, the Frontera fiefdom would become the symbol of peace and restoration. Once that happened, Lloyd would be able to two-time the two kingdoms without being accused of treason and under the blessing of everyone.

Plus, I have a useful title with me.

Lloyd recalled the very first title he had earned. Magentano Carry. The effect of the title enabled him to be absolutely free from receiving doubts of treason during the queen’s reign. In other words, as long as he didn’t act like a complete idiot, he wouldn’t be accused of treason.

“So, Queen Magentano won’t express any complaints though she may feel somewhat upset about the marriage. No, she might even give us more favors in fear of us getting closer to the sultan.”

“And that is how... the queen will not be able to use you like a slave...” Javier postulated.

“Yeah,” said Lloyd brightly. “It’ll look like I’d rush right into the arms of the sultan if she tried to do that.”

“...”

“The sultan will welcome me with open arms. It was me, not Julian, the sultan wanted to be his son-in-law, you know,” reminded Lloyd.

“...”

“And that’s how I will gain the upper hand with these two kingdoms. They will be forced to be more careful with us. Obviously, this will also guarantee a peaceful retirement for myself.” Lloyd smiled victoriously.

“Whew. Master Lloyd... You are really...”

“Really what?”

“Sly. Nasty. I have never met a more cunning swindler than you, Master Lloyd.”

“Sure, thank you.”

Lloyd smiled after revealing the idea inside his head. This was the polished plan he had come up with. The marriage between Julian and Sheherazade would be used to prompt the queen and sultan to win his favor. As long as that happened, he could spend the rest of his life in leisure without needing to grovel at anyone or get called by the queen.

But of course, it’ll take a lot of effort for me to maintain that upper hand.

The final goal? To acquire the right to have autonomy over his labor from the queen. That was his ultimate goal.

I can do it.

Inspecting his plan, Lloyd looked at the manor. The window to Julian’s room was tightly shut. Sheherazade’s window was also shut but with a layer of a curtain drawn. Looking from one to another, Lloyd smiled.

Yes, you two. Think about your feelings. Ponder on them. React to the arrow of realization I pierced in each of you.

The arrows had already been released, hitting their target spot on. So, Lloyd was confident. Julian and Sheherazade would react just the way he hoped they would. And indeed, his expectations were not wrong. Something really did happen deep into that night.

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Chapter 209: Between an Order and Request (1)

Wahaha. Who knew that things would go this well?

It was a hot summer night. But being a young dragon himself, Solitas didn't mind the heat at all as he sauntered around. Instead, he simply clenched his fists for what he was able to achieve.

I did it. I did it. I finally mastered the wood block.

Solitas recalled what happened earlier in the day. He was wrestling with a wood block like any other day. He sliced, carved, and refined the wood to a size smaller than his nail. He was keeping his mind on the job when he heard a voice beside him.

"That will be enough. Let's move to the next step." It was Corgidus, his teacher.

Solitas wondered when his teacher had approached him and started to watch him work. He had been so focused that he didn't notice Corgidus's presence. But what surprised him more was the unexpected comment that came out of his teacher's mouth. Corgidus let out a snort at him.

"At this point, you can move on from the wood blocks," Corgidus said. "I am more proud of you because I can see that you have put a lot of effort in your own way."

"Th-then..." muttered Solitas, feeling expectant.

"Tomorrow, we will start carving stones."

Corgidus then tapped him on the shoulder twice as though he was complimenting him for a job well done and was proud of his work. Solitas inwardly jumped in sheer joy as he watched his teacher leave after dropping the good news.

I thought I'd never move past working on the wood blocks.

It was true. He himself could see how terrible he was with his hands. Even with the master dwarf as his teacher, he couldn't absorb even one percent of what he was being taught and Corgidus was becoming frustrated with him as well. But Solitas didn't give up.

I can't give up. I need to get married!

He had a grand wish. Getting married. Starting a happy family. He swore early on that he would succeed in this no matter what it took.

So, I didn't give up. It was really tough. Whew...

Solitas wiped the tears off his eyes with his sleeves as he walked along the forest trail. He became overwhelmed with emotions as he looked back on his hard work after coming to this fiefdom as Corgidus's apprentice.

The thing is, these jewel craftsmanship lessons aren't free.

Solitas had to take care of the waste sludge of the main canal once every month. The dung of humans, orcs, and the smelliest of them all, the elves. How self-deprecating it was for him to let out a fiery breath at the enormous pile of dung every month!

But of course, this will continue for the foreseeable future. I will have to take on more endeavors similar to this one. But it's fine. My craftsmanship skills are improving. I just need to work a little harder.

Solitas clenched his fists. He was now set to process stones. Next time, he would be working with metal, and one day, he would employ actual jewels.

Then I'll be able to store a mountain of priceless and beautifully refined jewels just like all the other dragons. I can do it.

If he worked just ten more years, he'd be able to confidently compete in the market for marriage. Solitas allowed his fantasy to develop and thought about the outfit he'd wear to meet his future wife's parents, where their honeymoon would be, the babies they'd have, and how they'd grow old

together. Then his reverie naturally evolved to select the candidates for his bride.

Whew. If I really get married, who am I going to marry?

Solitas was curious, so he thought some more.

How many unmarried female dragons around my age are there... Let's see... From what I heard before... about 17 of them in total?

Solitas counted with his fingers, listing the female dragons he could potentially marry. Just then, he recalled one more.

Oh, one more. The daughter of Verkis, the dragon king.

The daughter that resulted from a union between the dragon king and a human woman. She was said to be half dragon and half human. As such, her marriageable age was different from ordinary dragons, and this meant she was also one of his potential partners for marriage. But when his train of thought reached that far, Solitas shook his head.

Ah, forget it. What am I thinking? The daughter of the dragon king? She's way out of my league.

He was entitled to let his imagination take flight, but there was a limit. How could he dare imagine marrying the daughter of the dragon king? There was no chance they would ever meet each other, let alone fall in love. From the start, she was someone he couldn't even lay his eyes on.

So, I'll leave her out of my list. Whew. I hope my candidates stay healthy and safe until I stockpile a hoard of jewels ten years from now. Whoever you are, don't catch a cold, take good care of your skin, and don't get esophagitis from breathing out too much fire.

Just like that, Solitas wished for the well-being of his bridal candidates, one of whom could become his life companion. Resolving to work harder moving forward and get married someday, Solitas took a stroll in the middle

of the summer night, satisfied and content. Just then, a suspicious noise interrupted him.

Hmm?

Solitas paused his walk for the first time, and he pricked up his ears and focused on the sound coming ahead of him.

Someone is coming.

Whom could it be at this ungodly hour past midnight? He noticed two people walking toward him. Solitas sharpened his senses a tad, and he scanned the features of the intruder with a vision that transcended human capacity. Then he saw them.

Humans. Two of them. One is a man. The other one is a woman. At this hour? Walking side-by-side? And they are blushing?

Solitas swallowed in spite of himself, and he was able to recognize what they were the moment his eyes laid on them. A couple. Despicable beings. This shameless couple was rubbing salt on the wounded heart of an innocent dragon as they strolled together side by side. However... Solitas couldn’t think of any words to criticize them.

C-crap!

Solitas gritted his teeth. Here he was, breathing out fire and incinerating piles of dung just to get married. He was carving out wood blocks in a dusty studio all day in exchange for his precious labor. Yet, that despicable couple over there was heartily laughing and smiling at each other. Solitas was green with envy. It was unfair. But there wasn’t anything he could say to them.

Shoot! Dammit! I’m going to try harder once I start working on stones tomorrow!

Solitas held back his tears, feeling a shaft of wretchedness, and rushed to the opposite side lest that despicable couple saw him cry. The woman

cocked her head to the side.

Hmm? I definitely felt something from a distance. But it disappeared in a flash. What is it?

There was no way of knowing. But it didn't feel like a human. No one could hide their presence that quickly unless they were a sword master.

A bunny, maybe?

Sheherazade let out a sigh. Relatedly, her own bunny was beside her at the moment.

"Um... Is something... wrong?" Julian asked carefully, studying her.

"No, nothing."

Sheherazade quickly shook her head when she heard Julian speak in a concerned tone. She was thankful that the moon wasn't bright tonight. Julian wouldn't be able to notice the blush on her face this way.

Whew... I'm going nuts.

Sheherazade secretly nibbled on her lips. To be honest, she never intended to go on a midnight stroll together. Walking with him wasn't part of her original plan. She never expected it to happen.

I felt trapped inside, so I stepped out to get some fresh air for a bit.

She had confined herself all day in her room, pondering on what Lloyd had told her the night before about how Julian would soon depart for the capital. She spent the whole day stressing over the matter.

I don't understand my feelings.

For some reason, her heart had sunk when she heard Lloyd's words. And his words stayed stuck in her head from then on. She didn't know why, however. At the same time, she was nervous about bumping into Julian with such a disorganized heart. What face should she make in front of him? How

should she greet him? It was beyond her. So, she couldn't take a step outside of her room for fear that she would bump into him. The thought of it seemed scary and awkward. She worried that she would do something idiotic in front of him. In the end, she spent the whole day hovering around her small room.

So, that was why I came out to get some fresh air for just a moment.

Since it was past midnight and no one would be around, she stepped out of her room feeling slightly more relaxed. Hence, she never expected to bump right into Julian in the middle of this trail.

"Whew..."

Sheherazade wasn't alone. Julian, too, was taken by surprise. He never imagined her to be out for a stroll at the same time and place as him.

What am I supposed to say? I mean, should I keep walking with her like this?

Julian walked as he thought in his head. Should he come up with an excuse and take another path? The thought crossed his mind for a second, but he soon shook his head.

If I do that, Miss Sheherazade will look at me more strangely.

She might also get upset. Thus, this meant that he should continue walking alongside her.

But what am I supposed to say?

He had to come up with a topic to discuss. But he couldn't get himself to speak. It was because of what Lloyd had told him the other night. He was anxious that the feelings he realized he had for her were one-sided. He couldn't dare recklessly open his mouth in front of her. As they hesitated, they arrived at the end of the trail.

"Oh..." Julian gaped.

In no time, they found themselves standing in front of the manor. Realizing that, Julian hurriedly turned to Sheherazade.

“Miss,” called Julian, his voice diffident.

“Yes?” Sheherazade turned.

“Oh... umm.” There was a heavy silence in between his words.

“Good night,” Sheherazade said first.

“Oh... Okay...”

Julian wanted to tell her good night first. But she had already wheeled around and was walking into the manor. Julian nibbled his lips as he watched her disappear.

***

The night wore on.

It’s strange. I can’t sleep.

He blinked hard, his eyes wide open. Julian, now back in his room, blankly lay on the bed. He wondered why he couldn’t fall asleep. Was it because he couldn’t stop thinking about Sheherazade from their stroll earlier? Was he regretful about not telling her good night first? It was a mystery. No, to be honest, he knew why. It was because of what his brother told him last night. *‘You’ll lose Miss Sheherazade if you keep going like this.’*

“...”

What if I really lost her? What if he continued hesitating and acting like a fumbling idiot whenever they met? Would she slip out of his grasp then?

I don’t want that.

No matter how many times he racked his brain, there was only one answer. Julian nibbled his lips. It was fine if he didn’t know what to say to her. It

didn’t matter if they didn’t exchange a single word. Or, just strolled together like before and occasionally met each other’s eyes. Even if he couldn’t express these feelings he held, it was all the same.

I miss her.

He suddenly bolted upright in his bed and walked into the hallway full of darkness.

***

It’s strange. I don’t want to sleep.

Her eyes were wide open, and Sheherazade lay down in bed after she got back to her room. She wondered why she wouldn’t fall asleep. Could it be because she kept thinking about Julian from their stroll earlier? Was she bothered by how she had rushed into the manor after giving a hurried farewell, feeling shy and awkward? There was no way of knowing. No, she actually knew. It was because of what Lloyd said to her last night. His words kept pestering her heart. ‘*Julian will leave for the capital soon.’*

“...”

Julian, the bunny-like man. She wondered when he would leave. She realized she should have asked that question earlier. What if he suddenly left straight away tomorrow morning? What if their stroll from just before was her last chance?

I don’t want that.

No matter how many times she thought about it, there was only one answer. Sheherazade clenched her fists. She didn’t want to send him off to the capital like this. She didn’t want to hopelessly part with him like that. It was fine if they didn’t exchange a single word. It didn’t matter if they just silently strolled together like earlier. She wanted to spend every day with him from now on. And so...

I’m going to do it.

She jumped out of her bed and walked into the dark hallway.

***

Julian walked carefully and slowly yet confidently. He moved past the dark corridor that led to the annex. Taking down the stairs, he made way for the visitor's room with a resolution to knock on her door.

***

Sheherazade walked, too, her steps relentless and confident. She collected her breath, passing the dark corridor that led to the main manor. She went upstairs and stretched her hand out toward a closed door.

***

Knock knock. The noise from the door echoed aloud the corridor. Julian flinched at the sound he made. He was worried that he might be rudely imposing. He corrected himself. Knocking on a lady's room so late at night? This was obviously a mistake.

But...

He missed her. He wanted to see her even if he was imposing. With such thought in mind, he stared at the closed door. Then he knocked again.

***

Creak. The door hinge noisily rang aloud the corridor, and Sheherazade became nervous at the sound. She was worried that she might be rudely imposing. She corrected herself. Knocking on someone's room so late at night? This was obviously a mistake.

But...

She had to do it. That was how much she wanted to be with Julian. With such thought in her head, she stared at the opening door.

"Who is it-"

Could it be that she woke him up? Count Frontera appeared sleepy through the door. As soon as she saw him, Sheherazade dropped down to her knees and blurted the comment she had practiced hundreds of times to herself.

“Your Excellency, please give me your second son. I promise I will make him happy for the rest of his life.”

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Chapter 210: Between an Order and Request (2)

“Ehem. Hmm! Today, as we continue further into this peaceful season of fall and all our crops ripen, I sincerely express my congratulations to the groom, Julian Frontera, and the bride, Sheherazade. Moreover, my congratulations go to the parents of both the groom and bride as today would be impossible without their love and care.”

Count Ventura solemnly gave a speech. He was the officiant of the wedding ceremony and part of the diplomatic delegation dispatched by Queen Magentano. His voice was calm and authoritative, much like a professional diplomat. Silence gradually fell over the garden as he read aloud the declaration of marriage. Everyone’s gaze focused on the bride and groom. Julian and Sheherazade. The two were holding hands as they stood upright facing the officiant. A smile of satisfaction appeared on Lloyd as he gazed at the two.

Woah. I can’t believe this is really happening.

His mind went back to what happened about two months ago. It must have been the day after he acted as Cupid between Julian and Sheherazade. A ruckus erupted out of the manor in the middle of the night. Sheherazade had gone to the count and countess’s bedroom past midnight and made a shocking request as she got down on her knees.

“Your Excellency, please give me your second son.”

Her remark at that time still amazed Lloyd to this day. It was so incredible that he couldn’t help but chuckle. She and Julian had just started becoming more than friends the day before, and the former didn’t even realize her feelings until Lloyd personally went to advise her.

Who would have thought that she would cause this chaos after only one day?

That was something Lloyd failed to foresee. That was how outrageous and unbelievable her actions were. It was something he only thought happened

in soap operas. And the aftermath of the incident was equally explosive. The whole manor was turned upside down. Count Frontera, still in pajamas, sank onto the corridor floor, shell-shocked. Counter Frontera clapped her hand over her mouth and froze in place. The startled guards, who found them during their night duty, shouted to see if something happened. It was only afterward that they discovered Sheherazade on the floor.

According to the guards, she was said to have her gaze fixed on the count as she remained on her knees.

She was said to be ready to turn into a statue if Count Frontera didn't permit their marriage. Anyway, the whole fuss woke every servant and maid in the manor. It was the same case for Lloyd, who was summoned by Count and Countess Frontera to join a family meeting before he could even rub the sleep from his eyes. Next, when he got to the count's office, he heard another shocking remark, this time from Julian.

"I feel the same way about her."

One from Sheherazade. Another from Julian. The two relentlessly hurled shocking and stubborn remarks one after another. Despite that, Count Frontera's reaction was nothing like Lloyd had expected. He was not flustered anymore. He was not at a loss for what to do. Seemingly reaching a decision after some careful thinking, he put on a serious gaze and separately asked both Julian and Sheherazade whether they were being sincere.

The two nodded, of course. And that was it.

Count Frontera simply acknowledged them, and he didn't ask any further questions. Instead of asking an unnecessary question, he immediately picked up his pen and carefully formatted two letters directed to two different destinations. One was for the Magentano palace, and the other one was for Ahinsya. Count Frontera informed the two monarchs of the marriage now that he confirmed the feelings of the two people. Without raising any doubts, Count Frontera chose to support and believe in the couple's sincerity. He stepped forward and volunteered to take on the heavy

role of asking for permission from the two kingdoms and adjudicating the two parties. From then on, everything moved forward without a hitch.

Of course. Queen Magentano and the sultan have no reason to oppose this marriage.

Their reactions were just as Lloyd expected. Since a peace treaty had been signed, both the royalties welcomed the union and even went further to float it as a symbol of harmony and reconciliation between the two kingdoms. It was because Julian was the second son of the Frontera fiefdom, which had been damaged by the Monster Domino, and Sheherazade was the daughter of the sultan, the culprit behind the incident.

Plus, the sultan was obsessed with having me as his son-in-law. Though he would have preferred me, I'm sure he determined that Julian is a great alternative. From the sultan's perspective, he's the next best option.

Thanks to their union, the Frontera family had become in-laws with the sultan. The sultan would likely try in the future to use this as an excuse to make Lloyd his son-in-law. But of course, Lloyd didn't have any intentions to dance to his tune.

Anyway.

Jostled out of his thoughts, Lloyd looked up. Under the bright fall sun, the wedding ceremony was quickly nearing its end in contrast with the weeks of hard preparation that was put into it.

"Therefore... The two have vowed in front of everyone gathered here today to be together for life. Now, I officially declare them as married before all of you who are watching this blessed ceremony."

Pop! Crackle! Right after the declaration was read aloud, firecrackers went off in several places, petals and tiny papers of various colors flying about. The new bride, Sheherazade, tossed the bouquet, which blasted into the air from the strength of a high-level sword expert. The guests regretfully swallowed as no one could even attempt to catch it. The bouquet flew out of

the garden and for several hundreds of yards until it lost its strength and fell on a studio.

Thud. “Eh...?”

Solitas, who was busily processing gravel in a corner of his studio, raised his eyebrows. He was engrossed in his work when a bouquet of flowers flew out of nowhere and hit his work table. It was as if someone had sent him a gift.

“What is this?”

Could it be something from the wedding that was said to be happening today? Was this the famous “bouquet” that he had only heard about? Solitas raised his brows higher.

I’ve heard of this before. I heard that whoever catches a bouquet tossed by a bride will be able to get married. Tsk. Humans, really. They stupidly obsess over groundless superstitions. What, did they think I’d be happy to receive this?

If so, they were correct. Solitas quietly stashed the bouquet under the table, and a mysterious smile hung on his mouth.

Meanwhile, the wedding ended in a success. Julian and Sheherazade hopped into a carriage, their faces blushing red. The sight brought tears of joy to Count and Countess Frontera.

The sultan, who couldn’t come to the wedding in person, joined his daughter using a magic mirror that the delegation held up for him. He experienced a surge of emotions. Sheherazade was his favorite daughter, though he kept that to himself as he had to act cool on the outside. Any thoughtless show of favor on his part could make her the target of envy and hate from her dozens of brothers and sisters. There was a fair chance for her to wind up in a power struggle that results in a feud. And so, he hid his feelings as her father, waiting for Sheherazade to become a sword master who’s strong enough to overcome the envy and slander of her brothers and sisters. Once that day came, when he wouldn’t have to worry about her

safety as she could protect herself, he decided to keep her on the side and reveal his true heart. After all, he was a father before a ruler like any other person.

“Hahaha...” The sultan inwardly smiled in contentment.

The guests sent a round of applause as they filled the manor garden. Just like that, the newlyweds went off on their honeymoon with everyone’s blessing.

***

“Whew.”

Once the wedding ceremony was over, Lloyd heaved a big sigh he had been holding for a long time.

I did it.

At last, Julian and Sheherazade were officially married, and they were congratulated and acknowledged by both the queen and the sultan. This was exactly what Lloyd had hoped for.

That rascal.

The carriage, which Julian would be sitting inside as a husband, grew farther away. A satisfied smile appeared on Lloyd’s face. But was it because Julian had become a useful pawn for him? Not entirely.

I... just feel happy.

Originally, Julian should have died already. That was what originally happened in *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

The Frontera family goes under, and having no more money to pay his tuition, he gets kicked out of the royal academy.

That day, Julian was killed by a robber while wandering around a back alley in the capital to find a place to sleep. That was the original story in the

novel. But now, it’s changed. Julian wasn’t dead. He graduated from the academy with honors and became a husband to a woman he loves. Now, he was happily going on his honeymoon. It was a stark contrast with the miserable, meaningless death he faced in the novel.

And that’s all thanks to me, your big brother, you punk.

The same went for Sheherazade. If it wasn’t for Lloyd, who built the Qanat in the Kandahar region, she would have been swept away in the hands of the rebels and died before her talent could be fully developed. But the story had changed once again. She was alive, needless to say, and also a happy bride on the way to her honeymoon. What was more, she even obtained a recording of Lloyd’s lullaby last night!

Well, she’s now my sister-in-law. Haha.

So, Lloyd concluded that it was only right for Julian and Sheherazade to return the favor they received. From now on, they were to be excellent pawns in his game. Fully basking in overwhelming satisfaction, Lloyd watched the newlyweds’ carriage disappear.

A few seconds later, Lloyd pushed his feelings away. Now wasn’t the time to get emotional. It was time to check how well his plan had been set. Thinking so, Lloyd swiveled away, walking through the crowds of people leaving the garden. Then he greeted Count Ventura who officiated the ceremony.

“It must have not been easy back there, Count Ventura,” Lloyd said as he stood in front of the count.

“Ahh,” gasped Count Ventura in happy surprise, “Why, if it isn’t Lloyd Frontera.”

“Yes, Your Excellency,” greeted Lloyd, “I was too busy to greet you before the ceremony. I hope everything is well with you.”

“Things are going well, of course. And you?”

“I am doing well. It is all thanks to you,” Lloyd replied.

“Haha, your flattery is the same as always.” Count Ventura beamed at Lloyd like he was his lucky charm.

How could he not? The count was able to pull off the negotiation with the sultan thanks to Lloyd and received a huge reward from the queen. But today, they had a more important matter at hand.

“But Count Ventura, do you not have a message for me?” asked Lloyd with a soft smile.

“Excuse me?”

“I know you have one.”

“Haha...” Count Ventura let out a snort and looked at Lloyd in amazement. “Have you caught on already?”

“Well, I have a rough idea.” Lloyd shrugged his shoulders.

It was true. He had seen it coming. Count Ventura, Lloyd figured, would relay Queen Magentano’s true feelings regarding this marriage.

With tension building around his eyes, Lloyd requested, “Then should we go elsewhere? There are too many people here.”

“Yes. Let us do that.”

Lloyd slipped out of the ceremony with the count and entered the manor as they pretended to have a casual conversation. And they sat opposite each other in the reception room where no one would come near.

“Since you seem to have a rough idea of the situation, I won’t beat around the bush,” started Count Ventura. “Your guess is right. There is a message Her Majesty ordered me to specially convey to you.”

After that, he paused before he continued again.

“First, Her Majesty has made no official comment about this marriage. Her Majesty only mumbled something to herself with a scoff.”

“What did she mumble...?”

“She said, ‘Tsk, I have a job for that mole cricket so bring him here.’”

“Her Majesty has a job for me...?” asked Lloyd.

“Indeed.” The count nodded. “Do you remember Cannavaro, the warlock that you captured back in Namaran?”

“Yes, Your Excellency.”

“Actually, we have already finished interrogating him, and Her Majesty launched a punitive operation based on his confession. This happened while you were building the Qanat.”

“Punitive operation?” Lloyd said, the words sounding unreal in his ears.

“Yes, and it ended successfully.”

“...”

Lloyd was secretly impressed. The queen lived up to her name. She not only finished interrogating the warlock, but also completely took care of all the other remnants. That was much like her, Lloyd thought to himself.

“But what does the suppression of the remaining followers of the warlock have anything to do with Her Majesty calling for me... Do you know the reason, Your Excellency?” asked Lloyd, unsure.

“I do not know the answer to that question.”

“Then could it be an edict, this calling me to the palace?”

After asking, Lloyd swallowed. Now came the important part. Why the queen wanted him hardly mattered. Her attitude as she called for him was more important. Lloyd had paired Julian and Sheherazade because he didn’t

want to be worked to death and wanted to two-time both the queen and sultan. All of this was his attempt to put the idea in her head that Lloyd might get upset and side with the sultan if she treated him poorly. By creating alarm, she would treat him more favorably after feeling a sense of crisis.

This is my chance. And depending on his answer, I can get a sense of how she plans on treating me.

Would he still be treated like a slave? Or, if not, with more courtesy than before? He could make a judgment from her attitude toward him. Thinking so, Lloyd looked at the count. Just then, the latter nodded.

“Edict?” Count Ventura repeated. “No, it is not.”

Now, with a graver and more solemn expression on his face, he added, “Her Majesty has specially advised me to tell you that this message is neither an edict nor a unilateral demand for you to come to the capital.”

“Then, what is it, Your Excellency?” Lloyd’s voice dripped with anticipation.

“She emphasized that it was a courteous and polite ‘request’ from her as your ruling queen.

The moment Lloyd heard him speak, he secretly clenched his fists.

It was a success.

The queen’s unilateral order had now changed into a polite request. Lloyd felt the beginning of a seemingly menial but critical change.

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Chapter 211: More Precious Than Treasures (1)

“Please do me a favor and hold on for just a little longer everyone.”

Slash! As Queen Magentano murmured to herself, the wooden sword in her hand terrorized the air, as though it was engraving a lightning bolt or slashing into the empty space. Ultimately, it rushed straight ahead and struck the shield of a nearby knight.

Boom! Though it was only a wooden sword strike, a booming noise akin to a fired canon blared out. The blow left a fist-sized dent in the shield made of five layers of metal sheet. The royal knight holding the shield was not left unharmed.

“Argh...!”

He was hurled 26 feet from where he stood along with his crushed shield.

“Urghh...”

The knight writhed in pain like a caterpillar stuck in the sand. He felt his stomach turn and was drained of all his energy. However, he wasn’t upset since there were other victims aside from him.

Thwaaack! Clang! Thwack!

Each time Queen Magentano wielded her wooden sword, several knights shot into the air in all directions like a pinball. Of course, the knights didn’t just defenselessly stand still.

An intermediate commanding knight yelled, “Gather up and form a close formation!”

The roughly 70 knights left in the hall busily moved in unison. 40 of them gathered in close formation, holding out a thick tower shield in front of themselves as they marched forward. The speed at which they moved

wasn’t slow, even though they were wearing a few hundred pounds of armor, as every single one of them was a high-level sword expert.

Clack! Click! Clack!

The heavily armored and dense wall of shields pushed against the queen. Meanwhile, the rest of the 30 knights surrounded her, moving like a delicately running cogwheel. Then they lay a heavy, fierce siege from the rear as they quickly changed their bearing and locality in rotation. But soon, they were destroyed. *Kaboom!*

“Ack!”

The moment Queen Magentano flew open her eyes, the knight that wielded his sword at her was thrown 16 feet in the air.

W-what the...

A look of bewilderment appeared in the knight’s eyes. He was certain that he got her, only to find himself flying in the air by the time he came to his senses. Of course, his sword had escaped from his grasp. He couldn’t even lift his finger from the shock that ran down his whole body. And in the next moment, however, he received a mental shock that hit him harder than the physical blows he received.

Kaboom! Clang! Pow! Clung! Thump!

“...!”

His comrades started to float in the air, too. Everyone was flailing their arms in midair. It was an unseemly sight to behold. They all hung at the same altitude of 16 feet as though the queen had intentionally chosen that height. And each of them gaped wordlessly like a goldfish out of the water and exchanged frightened glances.

“You too?”

“Me too.”

Then came the drop. *Bam! Thud! Thump!*

“Ack!”

“Eek!”

“Argh!”

Eight knights that were floating in the air hit the ground at almost the same time. Even after that, the queen didn’t stop brandishing her wooden sword.

“I asked you all to do me a favor and hold on a little longer.”

She hurtled toward the close formation of shields, and like a lion pouncing into a flock of sheep, she ripped the formation apart in mere seconds.

Baaam! She threw one blow after another, never striking her sword upward. And yet, the knights that were hit by her sword catapulted into the air. She continued storming forward, and the knights shot upward like a strong gush of fountain water.

“Yet, why can you not carry on? Hm?” the queen calmly scolded.

Slam! Pow! She didn’t even use her aura and only wielded her ordinary wooden sword and natural strength. She merely struck at the most appropriate timing and angle and with just the right amount of strength. But the rest of the royal knights collapsed in front of her, unable to endure the attacks for even a second. The queen moved as if she was using this training to let out her frustrations. Even then, however, the tumultuous emotions reflected in her eyes burned fiercely, and refused to calm down.

Lloyd Frontera.

The name came to her mind as she wielded her wooden sword. She had intended to use his talent for a noble purpose. But now... Ha! She was more dumbstruck the more she thought about him. A part of her was even disgusted.

Is that how much he hates helping me out?

Lloyd was practically an open book to Queen Magentano. She could undoubtedly tell that Lloyd was refusing to use his talent and wanted to rest for the remainder of his life. And the marriage between the Frontera family and the sultan's family must have been pushed forward for that goal of his. She was sure about it.

Lloyd Frontera must have intervened without question.

Queen Magentano didn't even need to look into it. Lloyd must have wanted to two-time her with the sultan using this marriage. The queen was regretful about it. She truly was. But what Lloyd did wasn't a crime per se that granted her the right to lay into him.

It is Julian Frontera, the second son of the Frontera family, who got married. He is not set to inherit the fiefdom.

Moreover, this marriage was the perfect publicity stunt to taut to her people, especially at this juncture.

The marriage happened just in time when the sultan and I struck a peace treaty. The marriage between the second son of the Frontera county, which receives unwavering support from the royal family, and the daughter of the sultan. It's an amazing symbol of friendship between us and the sultan kingdom.

Going beyond just good, one would have wondered if the queen and the sultan had planned for this to happen on purpose. And that was why Queen Magentano gritted her teeth more.

Lloyd must have felt his chance had come. He must have thought he had now earned the chance to befriend the sultan without getting hated. What a sly man he is.

Wham! The wooden sword continued its explosive and emotional dance, and the innocent human punching bags, the royal knights, collapsed to the ground like dominos. Queen Magentano continued her train of thought.

It must probably be because he is chary of staying under my influence. Through this marriage, he is throwing a modest, quite elusive message, a protest, that he can get closer to the sultan if he wishes to and will stick to the latter if I treat him badly. That is why I find him more disgusting but cute.

Grit! She clenched her teeth. Lloyd Frontera. She wanted to kick Lloyd's gut for being detestable. She wanted to harass him the more he struggled to tear himself away from her. She longed to drown him in work the more he fumbled to escape, assign him to lifelong labor and watch him flounder in misery, and watch him wretchedly beg in tears for a break.

"Agh...!"

Boom! A knight was hurled 16 feet away as he clutched his stomach. That was the last of it. Her insolent gaze swept over the surroundings. Not a single knight was standing near her.

"Tsk."

She wanted to stretch her body a little more. Dealing with the knights hadn't even made her break a sweat. Recently, ever since she ramped up her level once more, training with the knights wasn't enough for her. Around the time she was growing dissatisfied...

"Your Majesty, Lloyd Frontera has arrived," an official reported brightly in the corner of a training.

The corners of her lips rolled up ferociously. The timing was perfect. She was enticed by this opportunity to harass Lloyd.

Suppressing the strong desire, she said, "Let him wait."

After dropping the wooden sword, she walked out of the training hall and she took a swig of a glass of cold water. When she passed the long driveway and garden, she spotted Lloyd down on one knee.

“Lloyd Frontera is honored to be in the audience of Her Majesty,” announced Lloyd when he sensed her presence.

“...”

The queen felt a sudden impulse to slap the back of her head as she stared at his brazen actions. He would helplessly fall and roll to the ground. That sight would be exhilarating to watch, she thought to herself. But then, just barely holding back her impulse, she spoke in a formal tone.

“Follow me.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Queen Magentano swiveled and made for the outside of the secondary palace where the training hall stood. She passed the garden that led to the main palace, Lloyd obediently following behind her. He studied her very carefully, and the conversation between them resumed only much later.

“I see. Seeing that you have come here, you have decided to accept my request,” she stated coolly.

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd with feigned humility.

“Gratitude, my foot.”

“...”

“I will not,” she went on, “beat around the bush after calling you here when you want to rest. I will cut to the chase. I am sure you are well aware of how I subdued the remnants of the warlock recently, yes?”

“Yes, Your Majesty, I have heard about it.”

Lloyd nodded as if it was true. About four days ago, right after Julian’s wedding ceremony, Count Ventura gave him an update as he shared the queen’s request for him.

So, while I was building the Qanat in the sultan's kingdom... the queen achieved a brilliant feat.

Count Ventura shared that the interrogation of Cannavaro had ended. The man was said to have confessed everything when the palace laid a salvo of mind-altering and truth spells on him. The result was highly satisfactory. From the location, number, and plan of the remnant members, she was able to acquire almost all their classified information.

And she jumped into action right after, I heard.

Queen Magentano didn't even dawdle for a second. As soon as she was done with analyzing the information, she mobilized and led her armed forces to execute the punitive operation, eventually ambushing the enemy's cave like a bolt of lightning without giving them any time to react.

"I am glad that you have heard already," said Queen Magentano as she kept walking. "Then you must know that I slaughtered every single one of them, yes?"

"Certainly, Your Majesty," said Lloyd.

What the queen was saying was true. It was a clear fact that she had wiped out all their souls.

And in the process, she was said to manifest a sword skill that is much stronger than before.

According to Count Ventura, at the last portion of the battle, the queen personally beheaded the leader of the warlocks, showcasing an aura more iridescent than an ordinary sword master in the process. Thanks to her, the forces suffered less damage.

The queen has grown to be stronger than in the novel.

It was a mystery to Lloyd how much stronger she had gotten. But he knew that it was by a considerable increase.

In the novel, she loses an arm and turns into a tyrant.

After she lost her arm, she overlooked training. But now, it was a different story.

I suppose the assassination attempt terribly motivated her.

That thought crossed Lloyd for a second. It didn't seem far-fetched since he always found her coming out of training whenever he requested an audience with the queen after the assassination incident. In short, this meant that she was subjecting herself to intense training every day.

I pity the royal knights.

Those who were involved in the daily training of the queen could have the lowest job satisfaction in the whole kingdom. Lloyd was quite sure of it.

I guess they're the victims of the changes I created in history. Tsk.

Lloyd licked his lips, feeling slightly apologetic toward the royal knights. Meanwhile, the queen continued to speak.

"Anyway, I acquired an unexpected bundle of spoils after subduing the enemies. That is why I called you."

"Are they related to me, Your Majesty?" Lloyd asked, intrigued.

"If I want them to be, they are. After all, I plan on entrusting you with a construction project that will make use of this."

"Construction project... Your Majesty?" Lloyd's voice trembled.

"Indeed." She nodded. "Why? Do you not want to do it?"

"Um..." Lloyd was about to answer when he clamped his mouth shut.

The queen paused her walk before he realized it. She was staring at Lloyd with a fierce gaze, which seemed to say, "You better pick your next words very carefully."

Gulp. As soon as Lloyd saw her gaze, he had a realization.

She is aware of my plans already.

The queen was something indeed. Lloyd realized this once more.

I just sought my chance after observing the countless turn of events.

In the end, he succeeded in pairing Julian and Sheherazade. He was now able to two-time both the queen and sultan without being blamed by the other. And thanks to that, unilateral “orders” from the queen were changed into “requests.” Or so Lloyd thought. But now, he realized...

I guess it’s too early for that right now.

It was too early for him to bluntly reject the queen and express his unwillingness to do the work she requested of him.

It’s the case even if I’m holding the Magentano Carry title.

The title granted a powerful benefit, but it wasn’t absolute. Lloyd’s behavior could alter the valid period of the title, like, for example, right now.

If I upset her now, it’s over.

A powerful hunch came over Lloyd. If he behaved cluelessly and stubbornly, the title “Magentano Carry” that liberated him from any suspicion of treason could be shortened or completely eliminated. As the bad feeling gripped Lloyd, he decided to act like an elusive cockroach that sneaked around a kitchen sink at night. In other words, he immediately changed his attitude and began sincerely groveling at her.

“I, Lloyd Frontera,” said Lloyd in a grave tone, “have been waiting day and night until Your Majesty assigned me to a new project. Please grant me any task of your wish, Your Majesty.”

“Truly?” asked the queen, her voice grave.

“Truly, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd, stressing his words.

“Really?”

“Certainly, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“How naturally the eldest son of the Frontera family spews lies out of his mouth.”

“...”

“As if anybody in this world likes to work.”

“Uhm, that is because-”

“Enough. I am aware of your true feelings already.” Her voice was now softer. “What purpose and reason you had when you cajoled your brother into marrying the sultan’s daughter. Thus, I would like to give you a special reminder.”

“...”

Queen Magentano’s eyes held a glint of something mysterious.

“I like you,” the queen revealed. “You please me. Therefore, I will not be careless and incessant toward you. However...”

She looked at him a tad more sharply.

“Do not get too close to my enemy. Do not indiscreetly test my favor. Am I clear?”

“I shall keep that in mind, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd nodded earnestly so much that his upper spines hurt. That was only when her eyes relaxed.

“As I thought, you catch on quickly.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“I do not need your gratitude that you so easily speak of every time you are out of things to say.”

“...”

“Anyway, since you know where I stand, it is now time to reveal my assignment to you. This way.”

Queen Magentano led the way again, and Lloyd followed her. Past the garden, into the main palace, and after numerous corridors and stairs later, they finally arrived. They were at the palatial repository that stored a host of palatial treasures. Queen Magentano smiled meaningfully as she turned and faced Lloyd.

“Are you ready to see the spoils?”

“Yes, I am, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

What could she possibly want to show him? And what job is she planning on entrusting him with? The queen motioned while Lloyd was lost in thought. The royal knight moved and opened the sturdy door, revealing, at last, the spoil stashed inside.

“I order you to create a large garden that will reflect the global power of my palace using that.”

The spoil, which the queen was pointing at with a smile on her face, was no other than piles of bones from a dragon whose body stretched over 655 feet in length. Lloyd recognized this as soon as he laid his eyes on it.

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Chapter 212: More Precious Than Treasures (2)

Woah. This is just nuts.

Lloyd almost clapped his mouth over with his hand when he looked inside the wide open doors. A pile of dragon bones. A tremendous pile. It was nothing like the dinosaur fossils exhibited for display in museums. Putting the bones all together, much like the museum style, would seem to render a 655 feet tall figure. The skull alone was as large as a city bus. But there was something else that caught Lloyd's attention, and it was neither the size nor the scale of the ginormous dragon bones.

Three horns.

This dead dragon had three horns. Technically speaking, there were originally four, but the one on the left temple had snapped off. So, there were two on the head and one on the right temple. It looked quite familiar.

Of course. I've seen it a sickening amount of times.

That dragon's head and wings appeared in the design with the grim reaper. It was suspicious-looking as it was buried with the undead Mastodons near the Frontera fiefdom. It was thick on the ground in Namaran, where Lloyd had pursued after Cannavaro. And... in the novel as well, it was the pattern the secretive character used beside Queen Magentano the tyrant. The dragon head in the pattern looked just like what Lloyd was seeing right in front of him. It had a broken horn in the left temple and three other upright horns. It was the same as the dragon in the design he saw.

It's like they copy-pasted the dragon.

Lloyd was sure of it. This dead dragon and the design he saw then looked the same.

Confident, Lloyd said, "Your Majesty, I have something that I'm curious about."

“Ask,” allowed the queen. “Yes, Your Majesty. Did Your Majesty say that these dragon bones are the spoils you have acquired after subduing the warlocks?”

“Indeed.” She then let out a chuckle, slightly flashing a bit of pride in her smile. “They had it hidden in the deepest part of their laboratory and fought very hard to protect it.”

“Do you mean the remnants of the warlock, Your Majesty?” asked Lloyd for clarification.

“Yes. They looked like they were trying to protect a precious treasure. I presume it was the variety of potions, strong shamanistic tools, and many other goods that were extracted or processed from these bones. Much like the black jewel you excavated back in Namaran.”

“Do you know about them, Your Majesty?” Lloyd said in a surprised tone.

The queen smiled wryly before saying, “I heard it when Cannavaro confessed. The thing is, the man repeated his words five times even when I did not ask him to. I suppose that is how wretched he felt for being robbed of his stones.”

“...”

“Anyway,” she went on, “I was only able to acquire it after killing the last leader and the rest of the others. In all honesty, I was shocked when I first laid my eyes on this.”

The queen’s eyes held a glint of satisfaction as they fixed on the bones. Lloyd thought it natural.

I mean, we’re talking about dragon bones here.

Dragon bones themselves were high in value and also a powerful source of magic for extracting mana, much like what those dark magicians did. Otherwise, they could be processed to create battle gear. Given their

priceless value and rarity, it was only natural for the queen to candidly express her satisfaction with procuring an entire dragon head.

Moreover, the queen may be unaware of this, but if my guess is correct, she just made a remarkable accomplishment by suppressing the dark remnants.

Was it because she merely eradicated the remaining warlocks? Or because she acquired a pile of precious dragon bones? No. From Lloyd's perspective, her feat held more significance and meaning behind it. More precisely, she seemed to have exposed the dark secret that lay hidden in *The Knight of Blood and Iron*.

I'm almost certain. The horns of the dragon head. The dragon head grim reaper symbol. They're the same. What else could that mean?

It proved that the warlocks were the dark powers that used the symbol and were responsible for burying the Mastodons near the Frontera fiefdom. And... one of them had been a parasite that stuck to the queen in the original novel.

But, wow, it was all resolved with this one incident.

The identity of the parasitic official, who never left the queen's side, was hidden in veils even when part one of the novel ended. Every reader expected this secret to be revealed in the sequel, but it never came out as the author stopped midway.

So, I was quite bothered by it. I couldn't pinpoint who these guys were even after reading the novel. I was afraid that they might suddenly attack me in the future.

But now, the queen had taken care of them in one clean sweep. It felt like a terrible migraine was forever gone and like someone had paid off his debt for him. The more he chewed over the fact, he felt a greater desire to bow down in front of the queen.

She must not know what kind of extraordinary feat she achieved.

Lloyd suppressed his laughter. This was good. The pests were now taken care of. He didn't even have to lift his finger in the process. This incident was akin to a mosquito plunging into the water in a sink and dying on its own without the help of insecticide. The enemy was now gone, and he passionately welcomed this turn of events.

Concluding his thoughts, Lloyd asked, "So, does Your Majesty wish to construct a large garden using these dragon bones?"

"Indeed. I am thinking of assembling the dragon bones to make it look like it's bowing down to a statue across from it."

"By statue, do you mean the statue of Your Majesty?"

"That is right. This is why it is convenient to work with you," she complimented with a nod. "You see through my thoughts without any explanation from me."

The queen smiled in a satisfying manner and continued to speak.

"You may wonder as to why I am using these precious dragon bones to decorate the garden and create a sculpture. Is it simply vanity? No. There is a more important reason."

"Is it," put in Lloyd, "to exhibit the power of the House of Magentano to the outside world, Your Majesty?"

"Did you notice that already?"

"Yes, Your Majesty, a little bit..."

"Your guess is correct." She paused before continuing. "At this juncture in history, is there any power that can fight against me head-on in the Lorasian Continent? No. Is there someone that can dare overpower my military, wealth, or any other area of power? No."

Her voice was proud and equally confident. Lloyd nodded in agreement. It was true. One could objectively and meticulously attempt to go over her words, but one would conclude that it was fairly factual. That was how

prosperous the House of Magentano was now. In the 21st century, they would be comparable to Russia in a world without the United States. It wasn't an understatement to say that the Magentano was one step away from becoming a hegemony that ruled over the Lorasian Continent.

Though the sultan's kingdom is its rival, much like China is to the United States.

But they were on good terms now, which meant there was no real threat at this point.

So now, the queen must have judged that the time is ripe to elevate her power once and for all. Consolidate the nobles in the kingdom. Raise her global status. Preemptively botch any other countries' plans to dare challenge her, much like the sultan did with the Monster Domino operation.

The construction would be beneficial in many ways, socially and diplomatically. Come to think of it, Lloyd remembered that a similar instance took place on Earth before.

This happened during the heyday in France when Louis XIV ruled over the country. He mobilized massive funds to advertise the wealth and power of the House of Bourbon. He ordered the expansion and construction of his palace and garden. This eventually became the Versailles. And that part of history was taking place in this world with Queen Magentano. She was revealing her demands with a gaze as solemn as that of Louis XIV.

"I am thinking of expanding the back garden of the main palace," she said, making one of her many demands.

Yes, my dear client.

"Moreover, I want the expansion of the back garden to cover more than 800 hectares, and the path that will be laid out in the garden should be over 12 miles along with a waterway that stretches over 18 miles."

Why, yes, my dear client.

“More than 200,000 beautiful multi-colored trees must be planted, and the main garden area must have the dragon confidently blowing across from my sculpture.”

Why, of course, my dear client.

“There is one more very important aspect.”

Just say the word, my dear client.

“The dragon and my sculpture should be surrounded by a waterway that’s wide enough for 50 people to freely travel by ship. It would be best to show the view of the ship entering through the waterway from the Magena River, and finally wading out into the opposite waterway to exit the garden.”

Please save me, my dear client.

There was no end to her demands and requests. Moreover, they were very detailed. Queen Magentano was the type of client who clearly knew exactly what she wanted.

Haah.

Although Lloyd was burdened by her meticulous demands, he managed to remember every one of them. To some degree, a part of him even welcomed her demands.

This type of client is surprisingly easy to work with.

Just then, Lloyd’s mind traveled back to his laborious days in South Korea. One time, he was called in to work on a private residential house. The owner was a hard client to deal with. But it wasn’t because he maliciously abused Lloyd or used his money and power as leverage against him and the others.

That man was a hesitant, wishy-washy, and indecisive but good-natured man.

Lloyd realized for the first time then that the most frustrating and troubling type of client to work with was the good-natured but indecisive ones who didn't know what they wanted.

I didn't believe it at first, but it really was the case.

The owner was definitely something. At first, he said that anything was fine. As long as it looked good, all was okay. He nicely went along with anything at the initial phase of the renovation. But as the project progressed...

He slowly started to change.

His demands started increasing. He slowly became more ambitious in his vision. Why?

It was because he didn't know what he wanted at the start of the project.

And so, the owner only came to figure out his needs midway.

"Oops! Now that I see it, I'd like the tiles in the first-floor entrance to be gray, not white."

"I'm sorry, but can we do this door in another style? Not this one?"

"I'm seeing it now, and it looks like we should get rid of the shower booth."

Surely, it would have been relatively fine if the project had ended that way. Lloyd and his team did reflect on the changes with a good heart. But the project wasn't finished with such a beautiful ending.

"Oh, seeing it now, I think I like the very first one best. Let's go with the first one."

Eventually, the house had to be redone all over again.

Dammit. Just thinking about it pisses me off. I worked my ass off and gave him what he wanted, and he what?

Stuck in his memory, Lloyd clenched his fists. So, in a way, he felt a rush of relief as he looked at Queen Magentano. At least she wasn't such an indecisive person.

"So, Your Majesty," asked Lloyd for a final go, "Do I simply have to include everything Your Majesty has mentioned in the construction?"

"Indeed. Combine all the elements I mentioned without leaving anything out. Do not worry about the cost and labor as I will provide more than enough. How does that sound, Young Master Frontera?"

"I think it is splendid," replied Lloyd.

"Is that so?"

"Without a doubt, Your Majesty," said Lloyd, hanging his head lower.

"Good. Then I presume you already have a reward in mind?"

"That is also without a doubt, Your Majesty."

"Do tell."

The queen and Lloyd had each other completely figured out. Each knew that either one of them wasn't an easy opponent. So, they didn't need to mince their words. Since the queen had laid out all her requirements, it was naturally time for Lloyd to make his own demands.

Lloyd Frontera. You could have returned home to relax, but instead, agreed to take up a construction project as large as this without putting up a fight. So, I shall grant you one request even if it seems a bit excessive.

Her gaze deepened as it was fixed on Lloyd. She regarded him as a useful talent since he was quick-witted and clever. But now, she felt a sense of discomfort about taking advantage of his capabilities unlike before.

Tsk. I never thought he would dare side with the sultan so shamelessly.

The queen never imagined a day would come when she would have to butter up Lloyd to do a job for her. She licked her lips in bitterness.

Sounding politely, Lloyd said, “With your permission, I shall make my request, Your Majesty.”

Being left with no choice but to work since it was too early to reject her orders, Lloyd decided to get compensated with something very valuable. He would make the best out of the deal. For example, ask for something luxurious as dozens of special full-set armors along with a two-liter bottle of a legendary potion.

“I, Lloyd Frontera, ask for a labor exemption period of ten years once the construction is completed.”

“What...?” The queen’s eyes shook. Her eyebrows were lifted.

It was a request that went beyond her comprehension. Her surprise soon turned into annoyance. Disobedience for the next ten years? Even you cannot dare make such a request! The moment the queen was about to rebuke him for his impertinence, Lloyd quickly added, his voice sounding shameless.

“Should Your Majesty find my request unfavorable, I ask for a large chunk of the dragon bone instead of the ten-year labor exemption.”

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Chapter 213: His Aspiration to Be a Slacker (1)

Viscount Nort. Soon to be 56 years old, he was a landscape architect with an impressive career. He was only a young apprentice when he started to show his talent in gardening. His hands transformed countless wild and ruined gardens into beautiful works of art. He soon rose to become a world-class gardener.

But his career didn't stop there. His focus shifted to civil construction. From simple landscaping, he ventured into designing the actual sites and divisions of land in gardens. Soon enough, he rose to become an unrivaled figure in garden construction and management. His talent alone elevated his status as a peasant to a viscount. As such, it went without saying that the man held great pride in his skills. In particular, he thought he was significantly above a young engineer who had just started to make his name known in the past few years.

Hmm, I suppose this is Lloyd Frontera.

This man was much younger than what was suggested by the rumors. He was practically a child. The queen had shared a few things about him, about how he is the rising star and how he'd join a large, upcoming garden construction. About how he constructed that stunning Lloy-Javi suspension bridge. But really, it never occurred to Viscount Nort that Lloyd would be this young.

He's young enough to be my son.

A flicker of vague dissatisfaction appeared in Viscount Nort's eyes as they watched Lloyd. A youngster that hadn't even turned thirty yet. What was he doing at the same age?

I was making my name as a gardener until I was exposed to design work for the first time. Then I had to work and study for ten more years. But this kid. He what? He's gaining a reputation as a developer at such a young age?

Truth be told, Viscount Nort was a little dumbstruck. He, who was initially a commoner, figured that Lloyd was different from him. Having been born into a noble family, this kid was able to happily study in peace. The viscount felt a surge of distaste, and his voice reflected his displeasure as he introduced himself to Lloyd.

“So, you are the eldest son of the Frontera family?” blurted Viscount Nort.

“Yes, nice to meet you, Viscount Nort. I have heard a lot about you,” replied Lloyd.

“The queen has spoken about me?” asked Viscount Nort, a shade surprised.

“Yes,” Lloyd said, “she said that you are an excellent developer that I should look up to as a role model.”

“Ahem. Hmm!” Viscount Nort cleared his throat. “You flatter me. I, too, heard a bit about you.”

“Is that so?” Lloyd looked at Viscount Nort.

“Yes, I heard you’re talented and quite accomplished.”

“Haha, you are too kind.”

Lloyd plastered a shy smile, and he thought to himself...

This man doesn’t really like me.

For some reason, the viscount was staring at Lloyd with fairly obvious distaste. Just then, Lloyd recalled how the queen had explicitly shared her sentiments with him a moment ago.

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“What?” asked Queen Magentano. “The dragon bone?”

The queen’s question came out in a snap, and Lloyd clearly caught the flicker of dismay that crossed her eyes, which was replaced with a hearty

chuckle.

“What? Ha! My goodness. Lloyd Frontera.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd pretended to not hear her reaction.

“The dragon bone must be what you wanted in the first place, am I correct?”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd quickly bowed. It was true. He was after the dragon bone in the first place. That was why he shook her up with the mention of a ten-year exemption of labor. If she didn’t take it, oh, well. If she did, awesome! Lloyd suggested his initial deal with that thought in mind. The smile on her face became slightly bitter.

“What you want is the dragon bone, but you used the labor exemption to attract my attention,” the queen pointed out in annoyance. “Why do you subtly keep bringing up the latter?”

“I wish to rest, Your Majesty.”

“Ha. And now, you say it out loud.”

“It is my genuine wish, whether it is granted or not, Your Majesty.”

“However,” said the queen in a reminding tone, “I’m sure you’re aware it is an impossible wish for me to grant.”

“Please allow a man to dream, Your Majesty.”

“You are free to dream, yes. Anyway...” The queen went on, her gaze meaningful. “A chunk of dragon bone? Are you aware of how valuable this is when you dare ask for it?”

“Certainly, Your Majesty,” affirmed Lloyd.

Lloyd didn’t even bother to avoid her gaze. He shamelessly responded to her in a heartbeat. “I believe it truly matches the value of the earnest work I do for Your Majesty.”

“Really?” snapped the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Ha. You are brazen.”

“Please forgive my rudeness, Your Majesty.”

“Fine... Just a piece of the tailbone.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“But it cannot be a lot. I will give you a small end piece that won’t be too noticeable.”

“I am overwhelmed-”

“More like underwhelmed, aren’t you?”

Could it be that the queen thought she snubbed him? A mischievous smile appeared on the corners of her mouth. It was a rare sight.

“Even so,” she carried on, “it will be a sizeable chunk that’s as big as a single carriage. You can’t possibly be dissatisfied with that, right?”

“Certainly, Your Majesty,” affirmed Lloyd.

“Good.”

Just like that, the negotiation with the queen ended. A construction contract was signed, and Lloyd was told that he’d be working with Viscount Nort for the project.

“Follow this servant, and you will get to meet him,” the queen instructed. “Since Viscount Nort is a talented man in the field of garden design and

management, he will be a helpful partner for you in this project. Oh, and...”

Lloyd was about to give a polite farewell and leave when the queen stopped him.

“Viscount Nort has tremendous pride when it comes to his work and accomplishments,” the queen said as an afterthought. “If possible, please be understanding of that pride of his.”

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So, this is what she meant.

Lloyd suppressed a wry smile from his face. He was confused about what the queen meant when she said those words. But he understood her now that he was introduced to Viscount Nort.

This man is jealous of me.

Lloyd could feel it. Viscount Nort was visibly displeased with him. His stare seemed to say, “You’re nothing but a spoiled brat who got lucky.”

His snobby attitude didn’t change even afterward.

“Well, anyway, now that I have the chance to work with such a reputable young developer, let me ask you a question. Have you ever designed and constructed a garden all by yourself before?”

“No, I have not,” stated Lloyd expressionlessly.

“Tsk. Is that so?” Viscount Nort frowned.

“Indeed.”

“That will be an issue. I cannot wrap my head around how you earned your great reputation when you have never built a garden before,” grumbled the Viscount.

“It was all luck,” drawled Lloyd.

“That was it? Hmm... Tell me, how many years of experience do you have in construction?”

“Hmm, just a few years.”

“It can’t possibly be less than ten, right?”

“It is.”

“Tsk, tsk, tsk. That is also an issue.” Count Nort clucked his tongue in pity.

“How exactly is it an issue?” asked Lloyd, sounding absolutely unfazed.

“You see, my boy, many years of quality experience is what makes someone stand out on a work site. Am I wrong?” Count Nort spoke as though he was talking to a child.

“You speak the truth,” seconded Lloyd.

“Do you agree with me as well?”

“I do.”

Then as though he finally saw the chance, he snapped, “Then I suppose you have no qualms when I take over the command of this construction project?”

“My, by all means,” replied Lloyd with glee.

“Really?” asked Count Nort in surprise.

“Yes.”

“But, if so, I will be the one who is remembered for constructing this garden.”

“I am aware of that,” Lloyd tonelessly said as he nodded.

“And yet it is all right?”

“My, of course.” Lloyd nodded hard to sound genuine.

Lloyd nodded as if he truly didn’t mind. With a bright, earnest smile, he happily welcomed and accepted Count Nort’s suggestion.

“How can a novice like myself work next to you side by side, Viscount Nort?” asked Lloyd, shaking his head. “It’s nonsense. Don’t you think so?”

“Yes... It is,” replied Count Nort, slightly dazed by Lloyd’s willingness.

“Yes. Viscount Nort, you are wise. What can a novice like myself know? I’m only known for a couple of noteworthy construction projects. My reputation is a bubble soon to burst. The achievements you obtained with persistence and hard work are much more legitimate.”

“Ahem. Hmm!” coughed Count Nort, suppressing his grin. “You definitely... know a thing or two, eh?”

“Oh, not at all,” Lloyd said, waving his hands. “I merely follow along by watching brilliant senior developers like yourself work at construction sites. Do you disagree?”

“Hahahaha!” Count Nort finally erupted in joy. “Is that so?”

“Yes. Honestly, I had planned on bringing this up first and asking you to lead this construction project.”

“Did you now?”

“Yes. If anything, I am sorry that I senselessly made you speak on this matter before I did.”

“Ahem! You do not have to apologize for that...”

“No, no. I am truly sorry. I want to express my sincerity.”

Lloyd then offered his hand. Viscount Nort heartily grabbed it with both of his hands and shook it politely. And Lloyd met the viscount’s eyes, tensing his own to appear genuine. And to top it all off, he groveled, “I am honored

to support an excellent man like you, Viscount Nort, for this construction. I kindly ask for your guidance."

"Hahahaha! Well, well, the pleasure is mine. Ahem. Hmm!"

The viscount's face, which was as rough as a piece of sandpaper, melted away like snow in the spring. His chin lifted in pride and satisfaction as Lloyd buttered him up. An irrepressible smile hung on the corners of his wrinkled mouth, and he was slightly embarrassed by his attitude a while ago.

Oh my. I made a mistake. I simply thought he earned his reputation out of pure luck.

Count Nort had regarded Lloyd to be an insolent and impertinent brat. But now, he didn't think that was true. He realized from their conversation that Lloyd was an excellent and humble fellow with good character.

He surprised me.

Count Nort's gaze relaxed. He was a young man who knew how to respect an experienced senior and stay humble in spite of his fame. Count Nort began to see Lloyd in a new light. He had thought of the latter as an immature child just a moment ago, but now, he seemed quite smart. Seeing his thoughtful words and handshake, Count Nort could not believe how polite he was.

"I wish I could always work with someone like you. Hahahaha."

Viscount smiled with a glow of satisfaction. The change in his attitude rendered the same feeling to Lloyd.

Good. Excellent. Operation Moderation was a success.

From the start, Lloyd never planned on letting the queen exploit him. He also didn't want to take on this job in the first place. And here came the viscount eagerly volunteering to supervise and lead the whole project! Lloyd could only welcome him with wide open arms.

There is a saying in the military. Work in moderation. Don't stand out too much.

If you needlessly showed off, you would only be given more responsibilities and work. More often than not, it created hassles that could've been avoided. This was true based on Lloyd's past experiences as well. He remembered the first time he was given a placement. He was anxiously sitting upright at a corporate administration office when a sergeant walked up to him, asking whether Lloyd was really a civil engineering major and any good at shoveling.

Then I foolishly rushed to say that I was.

There wasn't any grand reason for his answer. He simply wanted to earn some brownie points by making a good impression. But unbeknownst to him, he had opened the hellish gates of endless labor.

Dammit. I should have stayed put at that time.

His life in the army wouldn't have been a disastrous wreck full of manual labor had he told a small lie or quietly said that he wasn't good at it. Wretchedly shoving aside his foolish past, Lloyd looked up.

"Yes, please take care of me from now on."

Please work hard on my behalf. In the meantime, I can relax and play around. Lloyd plastered on a sincere smile, and Count Nort, completely unaware of Lloyd's intentions, smiled back. And just like that, Lloyd acquired a hard-working construction robot. The construction robot's abilities were immediately uncovered the following day.

"Hmm," mused Count Nort. "Tell me, are you proficient in surveying?"

"Surveying, Count Nort? I just look over the area with my eyes..." Lloyd broke off.

"Hahaha! You eyeball the survey data?"

"Yes."

Lloyd nodded his head. A look of dismay appeared on the viscount’s face.

“An excellent and reputable developer like you conducts surveys with nothing but your bare eyes? That is a surprise. Then have you never used this survey machine before?”

“Oh, never. For one reason or another...”

Lloyd smiled in embarrassment. He had truthfully never used the survey machine after coming to this world.

Why? I have my surveying skills.

His skill could acquire data much more conveniently and accurately than the machine. Moreover, it could be used in conjunction with his design skill. But there was no way for the viscount to know this.

“Tsk, tsk. That is too bad. I don’t tell just anyone about this, but...” Count Nort motioned his hands to Lloyd. “Come over here for a second. I will specially teach you how to use the survey machine.”

Count Nort held up the surveying machine, which was made of a 4-foot-long supporting pole with a cross-shaped bar at the top. The four corners of the cross-shaped bar had threads and pendulums dangling from them.

“Now, watch how I do it. Erect the supporting pole, and arrange the crossbar. Like this and this. Do you see me?”

“Oh, yes...” murmured Lloyd expressionlessly.

“Then place and balance the pendulums on the four corners... Like this.”

“Okay,” Lloyd said with feigned interest.

“Check whether the pendulums are vertical to the ground. Like this.”

“Yes.”

“Now, take a look here. That way, you can accurately see whether the machine’s line of sight is at a desirable angle. What do you think? Is this not amazing?” asked Count Nort with evident pride in his voice.

“Yes, it is amazing,” seconded Lloyd, feigning his admiration. “I would like to observe you for a little longer.”

“Haha. I suppose I amazed you with my skills.”

“Yes, a little...”

“Then keep on watching and feel from the side how accurate and precise my surveying is.”

“Understood,” Lloyd played along.

Count Nort was as enthusiastic as he was prideful. What did this mean for Lloyd?

If I throw a few cheers and compliments at him, this man jumps for joy and does all the work for me!

It couldn’t get any easier than this. Thanks to him, Lloyd was able to sit back and relax. He was happier now than during any of his past construction projects. At the same time, Lloyd hoped that nothing would change in the meantime and Count Nort would complete the entire construction for him.

Meanwhile, I can enjoy a leisurely lifestyle here in the capital. Then once the construction ends, I’ll take the dragon’s tailbone and return to my fiefdom. Perfect. Just perfect.

It was a fact that everything in this world was better free. Lloyd beamed as though he had just won a coupon for a free year-long vacation at a hotel.

***

“How dare you... What are you going to do with my tailbone?”

Clack. In the deepest part of the national repository that stored the most precious treasures in the Magentano kingdom, something jerked in the vast and opulent space.

Clack... Clack... The movement was not significant. It was subtle enough to be easily missed by the naked eye. But the very entity that clacked was not insignificant. It was the head of a dragon.

“Once I am... done adapting to this new body... Once my soul is settled here... Then...

The dragon recalled the queen that dared to suppress and slay him and the young engineer that groveled at her.

“All of them...”

Clack. The dragon’s head intermittently clacked and pictured a dark, sinister plan.

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Chapter 214: His Aspiration to Be a Slacker (2)

It's painful and unfair. Just a little more. If only I had a few more days. Then all of my plans would have actualized as planned.

"Alicia... Termina Magentino... You despicable..."

Warlock Targa recalled her despicable face. Her eyes glinted coldly. The knife that pierced his neck was equally fatal and cold. That icy sensation was his final memory before he faced death. It only took one slash to disembody his neck. His head flew up in the air, and left a foul feeling as it rolled around after hitting the ground. In the last few seconds of his remaining life, he had to push aside his emotions and turn to his last resort.

He still remembered it like it was yesterday. Reluctant but absolutely left with no choice, he had to give up his dying flesh and transfer his soul into a giant skeleton. He was enraged, and his whole body still trembled in anger. And so, he resolved to be patient for just a little longer. In a few more months, his revenge would actualize just as he desired.

Once my soul is settled...

Stashed inside the flashy repository, his giant skull minutely clacked as he solidified his dark resolution.

***

"I recall you have never led a garden construction before, right?"

"Yes, for one reason or another," replied Lloyd.

Here we go again, Lloyd thought to himself with an embarrassed smile. Viscount Nort flashed a proud smile.

"It is all right," Viscount Nort comforted him. "there is no need to be embarrassed. Your career is just starting now, so this will serve as a good opportunity for you, won't it?"

“You could not be any more correct,” Lloyd said, “I am counting on you, viscount.”

“Hahaha, is that so? My, I feel like you are using flattery to pawn off your responsibilities on me.”

“Oops, was I too obvious?” Lloyd asked heartily.

“I can see through you, my boy,” cheerfully replied Viscount Nort.

“But I have no other choice. How can I dare compete with you, Viscount Nort, in the field of garden construction?”

“Gosh... Your words are nonsense...”

Viscount Nort flashed a toothy smile, and even though he waved his hands to stop Lloyd, it looked like the viscount was absolutely pleased. This made Lloyd more eager in buttering him up.

“No, no. I mean it. So, I want to make the most out of this opportunity and learn everything I can by observing you execute your design. As you have said, this will be a good experience for me,” stressed Lloyd.

“Ahaha. My boy, I see you are bent on stealing my design technique, aren’t you?” Viscount Nort crossed his arms.

“Isn’t that how everyone improves?” quipped Lloyd.

“Ha, it is truly fascinating. I don’t hate you even when you say those things.”

“No,” Lloyd said as he swayed his hands. “It is all because you are being kind toward me with your endless generosity.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes.”

“Hahaha!”

Viscount Nort continued to cheerfully laugh, and he soon spread wide a bundle of paper on the work table.

“Then will you look at this? I spent some time on the outline of the garden last night.”

“Could it be that you already started with the basic design?” Lloyd asked, incredulous.

“For there is no reason to wait.” Viscount Nort shrugged. “That land, that space where the garden would be put up, seems to plead to me for a beautiful transformation. It wants to reveal its true self to the world.”

“...”

“That is why I enjoy this process although you may disagree. I get overwhelmingly happy through the process of earthing the beauty, balance, and harmony hidden in a neglected piece of land.”

Viscount Nort spoke carefully as he looked at the blueprint. Gazing at his side, Lloyd thought for the first time that this viscount was a charming man.

This person truly loves to design gardens.

The viscount beside Lloyd was different from him, who materialistically accepted and completed jobs for money or another generous form of compensation.

Wow, this means that I can pawn off more work on him now.

I’ve got to toss some more work and praise to him. Then his happiness will probably soar through the roof. And at the same time, I’ll get to slack off. He’s scratching my back, and I’m scratching his. If this isn’t a win-win situation I don’t know what is!

From then onward, Lloyd fawned over Viscount Nort even more shamelessly. And the older man took up the surveying and design with sheer happiness written all over his face. But leaving every bit of the

process of the construction to Viscount Nort proved to be impossible about 15 days after the construction took off.

“Whew, this is quite troublesome,” said Viscount Nort in a worrying tone.

“Eh?” Lloyd asked. “Is there something wrong?”

Could it be that Lloyd had mooched off too openly? Had Viscount Nort finally reached the limit of his patience? But when Lloyd carefully asked what it was, to his relief, Viscount Nort was troubled by something else.

“It is because of the waterway construction demanded by Her Majesty.”

“What about it?”

“You see, you remember it too? The Magena River penetrates the capital. Her Majesty instructed us to pull the water from the river and create a waterway in the garden,” Viscount Nort reminded him.

“Yes, she did.”

“And she stressed several times that the waterway must be wide enough for a 50-pax ship to traverse freely and enjoy a view of her sculpture and the dragon skeleton.”

“Yes, I remember it, too,” confirmed Lloyd.

“That is where my trouble comes from. The thing is, hmm, paving the waterway is fine, but...”

Sensing a problem, Lloyd asked, “Is there a problem in the waterway design?”

“The water level difference between the two points, that is, the entry where the river water flows into the garden and the exit where it flows out, are significant.” Viscount Nort scratched his head.

“You must mean that the water current is faster than expected.”

“Exactly. That is what I mean.” Viscount Nort stroked his eyes heavy with fatigue. “The velocity of the moving water is faster than I expected it to be. Of course, we can float a boat on it, but we’ll have to give up on providing a view of the garden at this rate.”

“Hmm,” mused Lloyd, “you are certainly right.”

Lloyd nodded as he looked at the blueprint the viscount was pointing at. Indeed, the water level of the two ends was unexpectedly different.

They almost differ by 82 feet!

So. floating a boat in the waterway would be, to exaggerate a little, like turning a cruise ship into a flume coaster. A beautiful view of the garden? A magnificent sight of the sculpture and dragon skeletons? They wouldn’t even be able to dream of it.

Everyone’s going to be busy getting seasick or distracted from the thrill of a ride equal to kayaking in a rapid stream of the Grand Canyon.

After organizing his thoughts, Lloyd asked, “Then how about extending the length of the waterway?”

That would be the simplest solution. It would be similar to constructing a spiral path along a steep mountain to prevent any accidents from happening. They would gain more control over the velocity of the waterway by expanding its length.

Count Nort shook his head. “It won’t do. I have considered that solution as well.”

“Is there a problem with that method?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes. It is not beautiful.”

“Excuse me?” Lloyd retorted right away.

“The waterway is going to uncontrollably widen. A huge garden like this has a theme for each of its sections. Expanding the waterway would ruin all

the themes. So, we cannot use that method."

"Then how about using a double-leaf miter gate?"

"What...?"

Count Nort paused, unable to process the words he just heard. Double-leaf? Miter gate?

"Actually," Lloyd explained as though it was nothing. "It is not a complex concept. May I use your pen?"

"Okay, here you go."

"Thank you," said Lloyd as he took the pen. "To illustrate the basic principle... look here and here. We will shape the waterway to resemble a staircase."

"Hold on. But what about the ship? How is it going to pass the waterway when it is shaped like a stair?"

"That is why we will need a floodgate."

With a grin on his face, Lloyd drew a rough outline of a floodgate.

"The middle part of the waterway, that is, the end of the stair, is where the floodgate will be installed. It will close off the entrance the ship comes through, just like an aquarium."

"And next?"

"We can drain the water in the aquarium."

Lloyd sketched another drawing, this time in the area with a lower water level.

"Once the water drains out of the aquarium, the ship is going to come down along with the water level."

“Yes, indeed.”

“So, when the water level is sufficiently lowered, all we have to do is open the opposing floodgate as well as the one we just opened.”

“Oh...” Viscount Nort’s eyes glimmered. “So the opposing floodgate will become the ‘next flight of stairs’ in the waterway, and lower the water level. Am I right?”

“Yes, that is a precise summary.” Lloyd nodded.

It was actually a simple idea. Build a floodgate, a partition, that would shut the water flow at a particular point in the waterway. Let the ship enter, and close the floodgate, which would make the inside of the floodgate a square aquarium. Then add or drain water to control the water level.

If the ship traveled from a point where the water level was high and heading downward, the water could simply be drained. What about when it was going upward? They could just let the water flow in and balance the water level of both sides of the waterway like so. This way, the floodgate would act as an elevator for the ship, much like the floodgate in Canal Saint Martin in France.

“Of course, we can’t just thoughtlessly build a huge floodgate as it has to be able to bear water pressure. Based on some quick math, I think each floodgate can control about ten feet of water.”

“Then should we install floodgates all throughout the waterway?” asked Viscount Nort.

“Yes,” agreed Lloyd. “That will allow us to maintain the velocity of the current quite well, and let a ship pass through with ease.”

“I agree. Moreover, the passengers admiring the garden on the ship will likely become entranced by the moving floodgate. So, we will simply have to decorate the inside of the floodgate to captivate people’s attention once it opens,” mused the viscount.

“Oh...” gaped Lloyd with admiration. “That is something I haven’t thought about.”

“Really?”

“No, I never did,” Lloyd said. “I really never thought about that. Truly, you are a skilled expert, Viscount Nort.”

“Haha, how humble you are. Hahaha.”

Viscount Nort chuckled aloud, and at the same time, he was amazed. He gazed at Lloyd meaningfully.

This boy. I knew he was being considerate of me.

Actually, Viscount Nort noticed Lloyd’s careful behavior toward him from the first day they met. He was sure the young fellow was hiding his potential and refraining from brusquely acting as though he knew everything. He seemed to be wary of receiving praise from others and constantly lowered himself. It was the same case just now.

A floodgate, huh? I never thought to use that in the garden. But he carefully picked his words to make sure I didn’t feel embarrassed about it.

What was more, he even credited the idea of decorating the floodgate to Visount Nort, acting as though he didn’t think so far ahead. Viscount Nort easily noticed that Lloyd was being considerate.

There is no way a man who thought of building a floodgate here didn’t have that idea. I can tell that he is obviously trying to give credit for the idea and this project overall to me.

Why? There was no way of knowing. But Viscount Nort didn’t hate Lloyd for it. Instead, he was proud of this young man and appreciative for refraining from pompously showing off his skills, which were superior to his own, thereby saving his face. At the same time, Viscount Nort felt a rush of competitiveness against Lloyd.

I should work harder.

Viscount Nort wasn’t an unsightly man who relied on the favors of his juniors in the field. His skills were acquired through years of experience on the job, and his enthusiasm shot through the roof once more.

From that day onward, backed by Viscount Nort’s active guidance and Lloyd’s minimal participation, the construction of the largest garden in the history of the Magentano kingdom took off in full force. The House of Magentano generously supported the garden project and over 5,000 workers were hired. Even the royal magicians rolled up their sleeves, their powerful magic mixing, flipping, and rearranging the soil. Thousands of workers then used their shovels and tools in a fit of sweat. On top of them, Lloyd’s fantastical creatures joined in on the effort.

“Okay, you all. Dig, flip, and remove!”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha! Ggo!”

Ppodong dug the waterway. Bangul ate the dirt pile. Hamang filled the pond after drawing water elsewhere. Ggoming busily moved thousands of trees. And Lloyd even contacted the Frontera fiefdom to bring Bibeong.

“Bibeong!”

Throughout the whole process, Bibeong strove hard to show off his tremendous strength and great perseverance to Bangul by participating in the construction with all his might. As the fantastical creature, whose body size reached over 328 feet, joined the project, the construction speed increased to an incredible level.

Seasons changed. The maple trees reddened. The leaves fell. The branches thinned out. White snowflakes covered them. The year ended with its first snowfall.

With the new year, Javier teased Lloyd for getting older, and Lloyd forced a smile as he tried to look cool. Flowers started to bloom, and one day when the early spring came along with the full blossom of magnolia, “Termina Grand Garden,” which the House of Magentano completed to show off its

power to the outside world, was revealed to the world in its completed form for the first time.

A festival was held in the capital that same spring day. It was a grand completion ceremony held in “The Magentano Sanctuary” and “The Queen’s Advance Road.” The latter sat in the center of the garden and the former was at the end of it. The sculpture of the queen stood tall, and a skeleton of a dragon, stretching over 200 yards, humbly bowed down at the sculpture. Everyone at the ceremony let out words of admiration at the amazing magnificence they gave off. And that was the reason why no one sensed the subtle change in the dragon skeleton through the ceremony.

Clack... Softly and minutely, and yet certainly, the skull of the dragon started to move.

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Chapter 215: The Grand Completion Ceremony (1)

“Okay, ladies and gentlemen, please look over here. If you pull this lever, the main waterline opens up and drains the water.”

Cluck! As he explained, the floodgate official pulled the lever, and the pulley inside the floodgate turned with a metallic noise. The main waterline opened to lower the water level as the water drained out.

“Eh? It’s real! The water is going out!”

“Goodness gracious. What machine is this?!”

The small cruise ship waiting at the floodgate descended as the water level lowered, and the passengers onboard looked around the inner floodgate with marvel in their eyes. The inside looked much like a giant square water tank. Once the water level lowered to reveal the sides, there appeared a host of relievo-styled sculptures. It told the story of a vigorous dragon in the distant past. An acting monarch was elected by the dragons, who in the later years was surrounded by power-hungry, greedy rebels. The whole capital was set ablaze by the war the rebels stirred. One heroic knight appeared at that moment to save the aged monarch and drive the rebels away. People cheered fervently, and he married the princess of the monarch, eventually declaring this land as the capital “Magenta” and starting a new era.

“That... Isn’t that the legend about our kingdom’s founding?”

“That knight appears to be Sir Mikael, the heroic founding king of our kingdom.”

“I am certain it is him from the large flower on the helmet.”

“That flower was symbolic of the promise he made with a dragon in his youth, right?”

“Yes. That is why this flower is still used as the symbol for the throne.”

A piece of the Kingdom’s origin story engraved in the floodgate left a strong impression on the passengers, and their faces swelled with pride at the sight of the unexpected spectacle. They took pride in being the citizens of a kingdom that was growing in prosperity. Their feelings of pride peaked when they were taken to the center of the garden.

“D-dragon...”

“Is that a real dragon skeleton?”

“It looks like it is. Then is that... a sculpture?”

“A sculpture? Where?”

“Right in front of the bowing dragon.”

“Oh... It’s really there!”

“I think that’s Her Majesty.”

“It looks like the dragon is kneeling before her.”

“Spectacular...”

There was a dragon bowing down its head, and Queen Magentano proudly stood right in front of it. The masterpiece struck a balance between stateliness and harmony. The sheer size and power overwhelmed the beholders, and since the waterway was designed to make passengers look up at the sculpture and dragon, the overwhelming sensation left a more dramatic effect. They even felt like they’d become a part of the scene, watching history be made. Their unity in the dramatic moment boosted the passengers' pride in the kingdom.

Still feeling overwhelmed, they got off the dock, which was connected to the venue for the ceremony. The noble passengers attended the ceremony at the height of their pride for the kingdom. Of course, Lloyd, who was also among the bustling nobles, felt the same. His national pride was at its peak too.

How can buffet food be this delicious? Hurray for the House of Magentano! Big hurray for the queen!

The banquet hall sat at The Magentano Sanctuary, located at the center of the garden. It couldn't be any more luxurious. It was even so for Lloyd, whose banquet standards had become considerably high. This one appeared to have reached the peak of luxury.

This is a lot flashier than the time I broke the sultan's bank in Ahinsya.

Truly, all sorts of cuisines were served. Moreover, everything was scrumptious and literally melted on his tongue as it offered his taste buds the wonder of nature, much like the premium-grade beef he used to buy with his meager salary. And the best part? It was all free!

"So Master Lloyd," Javier asked expressionlessly, "Do you like these kinds of food?"

"Yeah, of course," answered Lloyd as he ate a forkful of mouthwatering seafood pasta he didn't know the name of. And he asked back, "Of course I do. It's free. What's not to like?"

"..."

"What are you doing?" Lloyd went on. "Eat up. If you still don't get it, then just put it in your head. In an event like this, food is what you remember."

"I do not-"

"Feel like eating it?" put in Lloyd.

"No."

"But why?" There was genuine curiosity in Lloyd's voice.

"To be honest, I am skeptical about whether it's really necessary to waste so much money on this extravagant food," Javier spoke as he looked at the food stacked high on Lloyd's plate. "It is excessively rare. Unnecessarily

high-end. Inefficient and expensive. The money that was spent on your plate of food alone could buy a large amount of rice and bread."

Lloyd noticed the faint glint of complaint in Javier's eyes. He smiled.

"Aha," said Lloyd, "I suppose you mean that giving up a small portion of this extravagant meal could help feed more hungry people in the capital, right?"

"Yes."

"Well," Lloyd said with a nod, "you're not wrong, but what can we do?"

"What do you mean what can we do?" blurted Javier.

"It's not like the food you refuse to eat will be distributed to the people."

"..."

"And we didn't spend our money on this," Lloyd reminded. "This banquet was prepared and hosted by the palace. That is why they prepared food befitting the status of this event."

"But such a luxurious event-"

"Is absolutely necessary," broke in Lloyd.

Javier paused. Lloyd gave a quick scan around the banquet hall.

"Will you look over there?" Lloyd pointed to one area. "They're the nobles from the palace, right?"

"Yes, it appears so."

Pointing to another group this time, Lloyd asked, "Then what about them?"

"They look like foreigners."

“You’re right. Probably ambassadors from nearby nations. Can’t you see?” Lloyd paused before resuming. “Events like these are a necessity, especially right after the completion of a grand and majestic construction funded by the kingdom.”

“Why is that?” Javier asked innocently.

“This place itself is a large, carefully crafted show window.”

Lloyd surveyed the garden thoroughly constructed with sheer magnificence. Javier frowned a little.

“By show window...”

“Yes, all of this is a show.”

“You cannot possibly mean that this is all a show to flaunt our power to foreign kingdoms.”

“Of course it is.” Lloyd grinned. “Do you think anybody can build a garden like this? The mere fact that construction of this size was finished without any difficulty proves our kingdom’s wealth. It’s proof of our overflowing capital, showing the entire world that this kingdom is capable of mobilizing and supporting an equally strong military.”

It was true. In other words, this project was not sham or overly excessive despite what it looked like. It was an indirect and clear yardstick to demonstrate the power of the royal family.

It was historically no different on Earth. The Versaille was similar to the Termina Garden. The Peterhof Palace and Sanssouci Palace commissioned by Peter the Great and Friedrich II, respectively, were also close examples. So, in a way, this was a sort of showcase, a remarkable event that displayed the power and wealth of the royal family both domestically and internationally.

“So, enjoy yourself,” Lloyd suggested. “This event and amount of extravagance is a necessity.”

“Um, but...”

“Oh, wow. Is that the special coconut from Ahinsya?”

Flinch. Javier, who was about to grumble, stopped. The special coconut from Ahinsya. The sweet and sour taste automatically came back to him.

“I got you.” Lloyd smugly smiled.

“...”

“Look at that. I knew you’d chow down once you found something you like,” pointed Lloyd.

“You are wrong,” denied Javier with a defiant look. “I was just tensing my body to hold back a sneeze.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“Really?” Lloyd waggled his eyebrows.

“Yes.”

“Then can you swear that you will never lay your hands on the coconut even when it’s right in front of you?”

“Of course, I won’t-”

“My, looks like there’s a real one here.”

Lloyd immediately snatched a plate from a passing servant. The plate, in fact, did have a special coconut placed right on top of it. The smile on Lloyd’s face turned more evil.

“Then I will enjoy my drink.”

“...”

Javier’s face froze in a flash. That gave Lloyd another smile but not because he was able to make fun of Javier.

Those reactions just now definitely suit Javier.

A knight who was always sided with the weak. A hero who pursued justice over immediate power. Lloyd suddenly recalled Javier’s appearances throughout the original novel.

Yes. Right. I forgot because he’s with me all the time, but he was always like this.

Javier preferred a conversation in front of a bonfire to a luxurious banquet. He preferred to use the money for an extravagant meal to buy dozens of bread loaves for people in need. He didn’t hesitate to act and didn’t come to regret his decisions. This aspect of his personality remained unchanged even when he became the grandmaster in the novel.

If he really wanted, he could have attained all the power and wealth he wanted. If he really made an effort, he could easily have had his own kingdom.

But Javier didn’t.

He’s really quite the man.

Lloyd picked up the coconut with a grin and held it out to Javier.

“No need to stiffen your face like that. Eat it.”

“...”

“I won’t judge.” Lloyd held it out some more. “Eat it, I tell you.”

“...”

“Hey, eating comes first before swearing,” Lloyd insisted.

“I never swore.” At last, a wry smile appeared on Javier, and he was about to receive the coconut when...

Clack! Crush!

“...!”

An abrupt and blaring noise bellowed, and Lloyd wheeled around in surprise.

“Woah.”

The dragon skeleton that decorated the central garden and was assembled like a dinosaur fossil displayed in museums was now missing a skull, which had fallen to the ground.

What is happening?

Lloyd was flustered. That shouldn’t have been able to fall off so easily. He had overseen the installation himself. An intricate wiring of metal chains and support fixtures tightly held the pieces together.

I suppose it’s good that no one got crushed under it at least?

But for an accident like that to occur during a showcase event. Lloyd clicked his tongue to himself and watched the scene. There was a stir among the people in the hall. Queen Magentano was now up from her seat and giving orders to the people around her. Two people were being summoned to her, and it was the sculptor in charge of installing the sculpture and dragon skeleton and Viscount Nort who oversaw the garden construction.

Whew. My dear viscount is going to have to write a thick report on this one. Lloyd felt pity while watching the back of Count Nort as he restlessly squirmed in front of the queen’s presence. How could he not?

That man was a bit strict but nice to me.

The viscount was willing to do the majority of the design and construction work. Thanks to that, Lloyd could just focus on building the waterway and floodgate. It really made his job easier to do during the entire construction.

Plus, Viscount Nort even cried in overwhelming happiness when the construction ended.

Lloyd recalled how Viscount Nort called it the greatest masterpiece of his life. He had sobbed and wept that he could die happy now as his name would be remembered in the kingdom's history of construction. An accident like this during the completion ceremony was completely unexpected.

Tsk, tsk, tsk. This is why you should never be too willing to bear responsibility.

A part of Lloyd felt sorry for the man, but another part of him was relieved. It really gladdened him that he didn't decide to supervise the whole construction.

"Master Lloyd." Javier tapped Lloyd's shoulder twice as he called.

"Eh?"

"I have something to tell you." Javier's voice was grim.

"What is it?" demanded Lloyd. "Do you want some more coconuts?"

"It is not that," refused Javier. "It's about that dragon skeleton over there."

"The skeleton? What about it?"

"Something feels a bit off."

"..."

Javier's expression and gaze were stern, grim, and serious. The situation felt oddly nostalgic. Lloyd briefly racked his brain and was able to quickly recall why.

Oh, right. It was at Cremo. There was a completion ceremony there too.

That completion ceremony celebrated the completion of the mermaid statue. And the Gigatitan swept over the banquet hall. Javier was the first to sense danger before anyone else. As Lloyd continued thinking, he was gripped with an uneasy feeling.

“What is it now?” blurted Lloyd. “You’re not going to say something’s wrong with the dragon skeleton, are you?”

“Yes, I was about to tell you that.” Javier was dead serious. Lloyd’s heart sank.

Oh, come on! This was why completion ceremonies were the worst. Come to think of it, Lloyd said to himself, it was at the completion ceremony of the suspension bridge when the queen was almost assassinated as well. This was too unlucky for it to be a mere coincidence. Could it be that completion ceremonies were the root of evil? Javier continued to speak as this outrageous thought went on in Lloyd’s head.

“I have been feeling this since a while ago, but the mana in the skeleton is faintly moving.”

“What? The mana is moving?” asked Lloyd in an incredulous tone.

“Yes. Don’t dragon bones naturally hold a small amount of mana?”

“They do, but the mana shouldn’t be flowing. It’s dead.”

“Yes. That was definitely true until just earlier. But right after the skull fell off...”

“It started to flow?” asked Lloyd in an incredulous voice.

“Check it for yourself, Master Lloyd.”

“...”

It dawned on Lloyd that the Asrahan Core Technique was a skill that specialized in mana detection, absorption, and employment. Moreover, Javier was the inventor and leading expert of the technique. So, it was impossible for him to be wrong.

"..."

As the uneasy feeling in his stomach spread out in him, Lloyd rotated his triple circle. *Ziiing!*

As the Asrahan Core Technique began to work, he could feel the flow of mana around him. He picked up the powerful mana belonging to the queen from the other side and the mana stirring among the people at the unexpected event. There was also a natural one present in the drifting wind. And...

"Dammit."

The moment Lloyd picked up a mana flow in the dragon skeleton, shivers ran down his spine. He was sure of it. Javier was right. There really was mana flowing inside the dragon skeleton. What was more, the flow was getting stronger even while he could feel it. The mana was aggressive and explosive.

Gulp. So, something was behind this. A terrible event that no one expected was about to implode in this location. The moment Lloyd realized it, the moment his bad feeling solidified into conviction...

Dammit! I hate these stupid completion ceremonies!

Lloyd immediately got to his feet without a second of hesitation. It was beyond him what was going to happen. But he had to evacuate people first. He was convinced that he'd regret it otherwise. So, he threw his hand into his inner pocket and brought out Bibeong to send everyone far, far away from the danger they weren't aware of yet.

"Bibeong!" called Lloyd.

“Bibeong?”

“It’s been stifling to forcefully stay small since the construction ended, right?”

“Bibebeong? Bibeong?”

“No, you must have felt stifled, I’m sure. So, eat this.”

“Bibeong?”

Bibeong had been eating a blue sunflower seed every day while he was in the capital. Lloyd held out a red sunflower seed to him.

“Do you trust me?” Lloyd asked.

“Bibeong...?”

“Better yet, do you trust Bangul?”

“Bibeong!”

The mere mention of her name made him nod hard.

“Great,” Lloyd complimented. “Then eat this, and do as I tell you.”

Lloyd fed Bibeong a sunflower seed and hurled him far away where there weren’t any people.

Poof! “Bibeong!”

A 328-foot beaver appeared in a flash, and he let out a roar in one corner of the hall and started to stomp and trample the ground. The effect was immense.

“Arghhh!!”

A piercing shrill of a noble lady became the whistle that caused all the panic-stricken guests to swiftly evacuate, prompting a mass exodus.

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Chapter 216: The Grand Completion Ceremony (2)

“Arghhh!”

“Wh-what... What is that?!”

“Run! No, move now! Get out of my way!”

The people scrambled, trying to outrun one another. Every single one of them was thrown into a maddening frenzy. The men had their shirt collars fly up as they sprinted, and the women threw off their heels to escape for their lives. Everyone looked to evacuate as quickly as possible, prompting a mass exodus. Bibeong roared at the fleeing group of people.

“Bibeong!”

The loud shout easily made their pace about ten percent faster.

What in the world is that?!

Fear and dismay gripped everyone. They were just at the bouquet simply enjoying the excellent food and aromatic wine, admiring the beautiful grand garden, feeling proud to be invited to the royal celebration, and networking within their social circle. That was all they were doing. Nothing more.

“Bibebeong!”

“...!”

And so, none of them understood or wanted to understand why they had to face this colossal monster in front of them and process what it was doing here.

“You over there! Run faster!”

“Here, take my hand!”

The people ran for their lives, flooding out of the banquet hall in a rush. Everyone ran and grew farther away, and soon enough, silence filled the previously bustling banquet hall. This made Lloyd smile.

Wow, I didn't expect this to work.

Lloyd wasn't sure, to be honest. Even when he brought Bibeong out, he wasn't sure if this would work as many people in the hall knew him.

It's unsurprising since Bibeong joined the garden construction and became a big help. Thanks to it, word spread about him amongst the people in the capital.

It was only a slight exaggeration to say that almost everyone in the capital was aware of Bibeong. The few who weren't would be newborn babies. That was why Lloyd was a bit unsure whether this method would work. He wanted to evacuate people outside the hall, but a part of him had doubts about them running away at the sight of Bibeong. Nonetheless, Lloyd decided to give it a try and hoped that using shock would work.

Honestly, not many people would have come across Bibeong in real life outside of rumors. Moreover, this closely.

It was a lot different to see a giant monster in front of your eyes compared to hearing about one. The difference was even more stark than seeing a skyscraper in a picture and staring at it from the ground level. Why? Bibeong could move and roar, whereas the building couldn't.

The length of his body alone is 328 feet. That's the size of a building. And imagine that kind of giant creature standing up on two legs, roaring and tap-dancing as his belly swings. It's only natural to be frightened and run for your life.

That was the effect Lloyd wished to bring about, and he expected people to run away from a skyscraper-sized, hula-dancing beaver. Even the ones who knew that Bibeong was meek and gentle would do the same.

How can they not? Imagine that there's a domesticated polar bear and it starts loudly roaring in your face. I'd be surprised if I didn't wet my pants. It would scare the wits out of me even if the bear held a coke bottle in their paw.

Anyway, Lloyd's plan worked just as he expected. Most of the guests were thrown into panic and ran for their lives. Soon, the whole hall was emptied, minus some dutiful servants and acrobats. Now, the royal guards started to fill up the space as they shot stern gazes at Lloyd.

"Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of Count Arcos Frontera, and his knight better kneel down at once and follow our instructions."

With an authoritative tone and a gaze more commanding than his voice, the royal guard commander spoke tonelessly, and Lloyd suppressed the wry smile that was forming on his face.

He must think I caused a scene.

Lloyd suddenly summoned a fantastical creature in the middle of the ceremony and threw people into chaos and panic by creating a terrorizing scene. Lloyd figured he would face serious punishment for killing the party. Lloyd called Bibeong as he carefully eyed the royal guard commander. He fed him a blue sunflower seed and put him inside his inner pocket. Then Lloyd obeyed the commander's instructions and got down on his knee.

"Looks like she'll come down on us this time," said Lloyd, "that is if nothing happens from now on."

"I did not expect you would bring out Sir Bibeong..." grumbled Javier as he got down on his knee beside Lloyd.

Turning to his side, Lloyd chuckled and said, "I couldn't think of any other way to evacuate everyone."

"Was calmly alerting the queen of the situation not an option for you," reminded Javier.

“But then I would need to receive permission from the queen. And provide an explanation for what we’re dealing with right now and persuade her. It’s too slow. We don’t have time to go through all those steps.”

Right around the time Javier and Lloyd were bickering, someone broke in their conversation.

“Now is the time for you to explain and persuade me.”

It was Queen Magentano. She was standing three steps away from them and looking down at them with an arrogant gaze. Thankfully, there was no resentment or anger in her eyes.

“Lloyd Frontera. I am flustered. The Lloyd I know would not cause this sort of turmoil without a good reason.”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“No, explain yourself first before asking for my forgiveness.” Lloyd realized from her firm voice that she didn’t want any formalities. A faint smile appeared in his mouth.

I knew she’d be wise.

Once again, Lloyd felt that the queen was extraordinary. She didn’t jump to conclusions, even amid this kind of situation. She didn’t readily lose her calm or temper either. Instead, she stared at Lloyd with a calm gaze.

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd replied quickly with calmness. “I will cut to the chase. I felt an explosive increase of mana flow in the dragon skeleton.”

“You felt a flow of mana?” asked the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“You did when even I couldn’t feel anything?”

“To be exact, it was Sir Asrahan who felt it.”

“...”

Her gaze toward Javier stiffened for a second. Lloyd wondered if it was because she realized that she was still behind Javier. But Lloyd brushed the thought aside as he knew there was something more important right now. The flow of mana inside the dragon skeleton was growing more fierce with every passing second.

“Therefore, I dared to do something unbelievable.”

“Was it to evacuate people as quickly as possible?” asked the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Moreover, I presume you determined that your ruckus would bring the troops to this place. Am I right?”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“It’s too early to forgive you,” said the queen. “I must confirm your words.”

At her order, a senior palatial magician hurried and walked over to the dragon skeleton and pointed his magic wand to it. After a prolonged session of focusing, he detected a flow of mana. Meanwhile, Lloyd was still down on his knee, nibbling his bottom lip.

This feels like I’m waiting to get my test grade back.

But Lloyd was certain that his test would get a perfect score. Unlike the queen, who didn’t own the Asrahan Core Technique, he could detect the flow of mana in the dragon skeleton in real time from a distance.

The flow is slowly getting more fierce.

It was almost like the mana of a living creature who had a pumping heart and pulse, breathed in and out, opened its eyes, and finally moved.

“...”

What if it really started moving? What was he supposed to do? Suddenly, Lloyd was gripped with an uneasy feeling, and he thought for a brief second. If he was right about his hunch, then there was only one course of action for him to take.

I obviously have to run away.

Just then, the setting in the novel hit his mind. Among the undead monsters who came back to life, the novel stated there were two that stood above the rest.

Hell's Knight and Bone Dragon.

The skeleton of the Bone Dragon itself was a mass of mana, and its bones moved using the mana as its source. The novel event mentioned that it was nothing short of a walking disaster.

Javier was the one who said it in the novel when he was still a sword master. That running away is the only way to survive when faced with such a creature. Theoretically, only the grandmaster could fight against the Bone Dragon.

The Knight of Blood and Iron. For some reason, the Bone Dragon was more powerful than any other dragon in this novel. To analogize, if most dragons were considered ordinary humans, the Bone Dragon was a skeleton. Just like how ordinary people could be beaten by the skeletons, most dragons couldn't be left unscathed after a fight with the Bone Dragon. And so, only the strong and powerful warriors among the ordinary dragons could defeat the Bone Dragon. What if this dragon skeleton came back to life and started to move? What if it was Bone Dragon?

I'll run without looking back.

Lloyd resolved to do so. Moreover, he resolved to take Javier, who was kneeling right beside him.

Of course, I should take him. There's no reason for either of us to risk our lives here.

Lloyd knew that he was no hero. He wasn’t like the superheroes that appeared in films. He was just an ordinary person who wanted to retire and enjoy his life. Fighting in combat? He didn’t have it in him. Sure, one thing had led to another, and he came to own the Asrahan Core Technique and manaheart in the process of overcoming some crises. However, he never expected to use them and show off his strength and power to other people.

I can do some self defense. That’s about it.

Moreover, if the enemy he was up against was the Bone Dragon, which only grandmasters could put up a fight against, it was only wise for him to run away for his life. And he wouldn’t feel the slightest amount of guilt about it.

The troops are here. And the queen’s here too.

They existed to protect the kingdom. And so, Lloyd didn’t plan to risk his life when there were people like them.

I pray that I am wrong. Come on.

With his heart in his mouth, Lloyd stared at the palatial magician and the dragon skeleton. Meanwhile, he sharpened the flow of mana in the skeleton.

Please.

The flow grew fiercer.

Haa... Please.

The mana flow became stronger. Lloyd gulped in spite of himself.

Seriously. Stop.

Lloyd begged inwardly that this ruckus would conclude as a false alarm. He didn’t care about being reprimanded by the queen. Lloyd pleaded and begged. Could it be that his prayer worked?

Eh...?

The mana flow suddenly stopped its amplification, and it gradually started to weaken like a Vitcoin graph after its peak or like the housing prices that would plummet the next day

"..."

Lloyd turned to Javier, who was looking at him. Javier nodded. He, too, felt it.

I'm sure of it. The mana is weakening.

Lloyd smiled involuntarily. He could feel it. The mana flow inside the dragon skeleton was sharply calming down as though it was never any different. The palatial magician seemed to have felt it too.

"Your Majesty," announced the magician, "It is true that there was mana flowing inside the skeleton much like what the eldest son of the Frontera family reported. But it is not strong enough for us to worry about it."

"It is nothing to worry about?" asked the queen.

"No, Your Majesty."

Pulling his wand back, the magician replied courteously.

"I have read records of similar instances as this one. To begin with, a dragon bone naturally holds a considerable amount of mana. Therefore, the records said that the mana flows on its own from time to time."

"So, are you saying that the mana flow that you detected does not posit any special danger or abnormality?"

"Yes, Your Majesty, I-"

Wham! Right before he could finish, the foreleg of the dragon crushed down on the magician.

"...!"

A fierce vibration spread across the land, bringing a thick, explosive cloud of dust. The dragon skeleton raised its head amid the dust and let out a roar.

“...!”

It was a silent roar. Without any vocal organs, it could only use mana to let out a roar, but that was exactly why it was so menacing.

Fwoosh! A shockwave of unadulterated mana blasted in all directions, tossing the banquet tables and smashing the podium in a flash. Trees were rooted out, and dishes and wine glasses shattered into thousands of shards. Everything within about 300 yards of distance was swept away by the force.

“Argh!!!”

One of the servants hurtled away with a shout. The guards tried to persist as they bled from the piercing shards of glass. Amid the stormy mana, Queen Magentano flew open her eyes in fright.

This... What... What?!

Her eyes darted toward the Bone Dragon. She couldn’t believe it. She thought it was merely a spoil, a tool that would memorialize her great achievement. But...

It can’t be.

This was not an accident or a coincidence. A shaft of doubt and suspicion arose in her mind. She pieced together all her memories related to the skeleton until now. She had brought the dragon skeleton after suppressing the warlocks and put it up at the center of the capital. Then there was a celebration ceremony. And now, the skeleton was moving and stirring up this entire area. And at last, Bone Dragon was looking down from a towering height. The moment their gazes met, she understood at last.

I was deceived.

She recalled the group of warlocks. An easy win, she thought. A great success. But that was a mistake. A grave mistake. She was arrogant to

regard so. As soon as she realized, she leaped high and moved to correct her mistake, her sword already shining bright with a brilliant aura.

Thwack! She charged toward the Bone Dragon's foreleg that was touching the ground. She wielded her sword, her aura turbulently glinting. But it bounced off.

Clang! "...!"

She couldn't scratch let alone split its foreleg in half. Terror filled her eyes. But she didn't allow panic to settle in her heart.

Instead, she calmly shouted, "Lloyd Frontera!"

Lloyd was the first person who foresaw this catastrophe. So, he was the most reliable individual at the moment. He might be able to enlighten her on how to break through this situation. She looked sideways and called out to Lloyd. That was when she realized something.

"..."

She realized that Lloyd was already far away and running faster than anyone else.

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Chapter 217: What the Queen Carries (1)

Huff! Huff!

Deep breath. Breath in. Breath out. Take a step forward, syncing your breath. Run. Like a gust of wind, the night air brushed his ears. Yes, Lloyd was running at full speed. He was trying to escape.

Dammit. Is this really happening?

Lloyd felt disgusted as he jumped over a waist-high patch of grass. Seriously, completion ceremonies were the problem. It didn't matter if it was perfect, lavish, or grand. Something bad always happened during completion ceremonies.

This is such an uncreative cliche!

Gnashing his teeth, Lloyd threw a glance behind his shoulder, and he saw a towering gray silhouette under the dark night sky. It was the giant dragon skeleton, Bone Dragon. And it was going berserk, making a wordless, mana-charged roar and sweeping the whole area with its long tail and neck. The sight of its bony wings spread out was even eerier, and it was fluttering like a spiderweb engraved into the night sky.

Seriously, how did this happen?

That was the dragon skeleton without a doubt. The queen had said that it was a spoil she had acquired after suppressing the remnants of the warlock. And so, he was even promised a piece of the dragon's tailbone after the construction was over.

Dammit!

At this rate, the whole capital was on the verge of being destroyed. But despite such a predicament, Lloyd didn't feel an iota of duty or lofty eagerness to protect the kingdom.

Of course I won't. Why would I fight against that thing?!

He'd have to risk his life to fight the monster. But there was no chance that he'd win even if he did. Someone could offer him billions of dollars to try, but Lloyd would still turn them down. With such a decision in mind, Lloyd continued rushing forward, but it looked like Javier, who was running at his side, was on a different page than him.

"Master Lloyd," Javier called, "where are we running off to?"

"Outside the garden."

"Then what strategy are you planning to respond with?"

"..."

Lloyd stared at Javier as he continued to run. Javier stared back, sending a gaze that seemed to say, "What's wrong?"

This scoundrel.

Then it occurred to Lloyd that Javier had misunderstood him. Javier must think, Lloyd told himself, that he was running somewhere with a great strategy or solid plan in mind. He must be expecting Lloyd to respond to the situation.

But I'm not that kind of person.

He couldn't be that sort of person. So, he decided to clear their misunderstanding first.

Pulling the corners of his mouth upward, Lloyd retorted, "Respond? Plan? What?"

"Yes," Javier replied.

"Um, if I have to put a name to it... Operation 911?"

"Excuse me?"

“I mean, run for your life.”

“...”

Javier’s face stiffened as he stared at Lloyd. On second thought, his face would be better described as angry rather than stiff.

“Master Lloyd...” His voice was now lower than a while ago. “Why are you always like this?”

“Like what?” asked Lloyd innocently.

“Many people are in danger right now. And yet, you do not hesitate to run away for your own safety, disregarding everyone else’s.”

“Yeah. You’re right.” Lloyd shrugged. And he replied nonchalantly, “Is that bad?”

“...”

“I think we argued over something like this before, right?”

“It was in Cremo,” Javier reminded him.

“You’re right. The Gigatitan.”

“At that time, you were-”

Lloyd interrupted him. “Yeah. I ran away just like now.”

“...”

“Is this really wrong?” Lloyd asked, meaning every word.

People who sacrificed themselves for others during disasters and accidents, like firefighters jumping into the plumes of fire and police officers and citizens helping out to respond to the accident, all deserved respect. They could be said to be the true heroes of this world. But what about Lloyd? He was different from them.

I’m a normal person. These kinds of situations scare me.

To be honest, Lloyd didn’t want to die. He just wanted to enjoy a simple life. He didn’t care to act like a hero or be praised as one. But it seemed that Javier thought otherwise.

“You have not changed at all, Master Lloyd.”

Javier looked Lloyd’s way, and there was disappointment in his eyes. No, it’d be more correct to say it was bitter regret. A bitter smile appeared on Lloyd’s mouth.

“I can’t do anything about it,” Lloyd said. “I’ll always be like this.”

“Do you mean it?” asked Javier.

“Do you think I’m lying to you right now?”

“No. However-”

“However?”

“Then enjoy living on my behalf as well.”

“Eh...?” Lloyd stopped dead in his tracks. He questioned the other man. “What? What do you mean?”

Javier was now wearing a face full of resolution. And he spoke with even more determination and sincerity.

“It was my honor to serve you all this time, Master Lloyd. I hope you safely escape from here.”

“Hey.”

“And please convey my message to Count Frontera that I am grateful for our time until now and to please forgive me for not being able to protect him longer.”

“Hey, you!”

Lloyd was flustered. Why was Javier talking like he was going to die soon? Why was Javier not responding to him? What was that faint, enigmatic smile on his face before he rushed off toward the Bone Dragon without a second glance? Lloyd couldn’t understand anything.

“What was that...? I got goosebumps from listening to him...”

Left alone, Lloyd let out a chuckle. Sure, it was commendable for Javier to head back to prevent a disaster, but was the overly dramatic speech necessary?

It’s no surprise coming from a protagonist in a novel.

That was the problem with fictional protagonists. As if it wasn’t enough to fight for justice, they gave corny speeches that made him wince in embarrassment.

Well, Javier was always like this.

Lloyd threw his gaze at the direction Javier had run off to. Javier was already gone. Lloyd could only see the clear outlines of the Bone Dragon going berserk.

“...”

He’s going to be okay, right? Lloyd brushed off the pang of nervousness and started to run again. He sprinted ahead to escape.

He’s Javier. He’ll be all right. Of course, nothing bad will happen.

Why? He was a sword master who could utilize the Asrahan Core Technique. He was stronger than most other sword masters out there. He was a genius among geniuses, surely to be remembered in history for his incredible strength, swordsmanship, fighting technique, skill application and variety, and ability to improvise. It wouldn’t be easy for something to go wrong with him. He wouldn’t die so easily. It was nearly impossible...

“Ugh. Come on! Why did he have to make me worry with those words!”

Lloyd bellowed, and he stopped running. Swiveling in annoyance, he glowered at the Bone Dragon.

At this rate, Javier will die.

He remembered what Javier said in the novel. The Bone Dragon. Theoretically, only grandmasters could put up a fight against him. But Javier was a simple sword master right now. So, rushing to fight head-on with the dragon would result in his death.

He won’t back down without a fight.

It was a reasonable assumption considering Javier’s personality. No, it was more than likely to be the truth.

If the queen is in danger, he’ll throw himself in harm’s way. And if someone else is in danger, he’ll rush to protect them too.

That was the kind of man Javier was. In the novel and their current life, Javier had remained the same. So, he would be no different this time. And that was exactly why Lloyd thought he’d die this time. He was a bit opposed to it.

“Come on...”

Is this what it felt like to leave a horribly obstinate friend at the scene of an accident? Lloyd turned back, gnashing his teeth. And he made for the opposite way, where the dragon was.

Fine. I’ll go! I’m going! You bastard! I will pull you out of that place, even if I have to drag you out by your ear.

Of course, Lloyd had no intention of fighting the monster. It was just senseless to fight against the Bone Dragon. His plan involved carrying out some gimmicks and finding a chance to get Javier out of there. The latter may censure him for being a coward, but his survival came first. Resolved, Lloyd ran.

“Dammit! That bastard, really!”

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“Please, Your Majesty. I am sincerely speaking. I beg you to quickly evacuate this scene!”

“No.”

Even though the royal guard commander loyally pleaded with the queen, Queen Magentano dismissed his request.

“If you genuinely wish to save me, you better lower your voice first,” she scolded.

“Oh...” The commander flinched. “Was I too loud, Your Majesty?”

“Yes, to the point that I am glad that the dragon didn’t hear us.”

Queen Magentano slightly moved her head, taking a peek through the thick screen of grass they were hiding behind. The Bone Dragon, unreservedly going berserk under the moon, came into her view. It felt as though no living creature could tame the monster.

The royal guards in charge of watching the banquet hall seemed to be struggling to not get stomped under the bone dragon’s feet. It couldn’t be called a fight or battle. They looked more like a swarm of ants fleeing for their lives from the tongue of an eager anteater. The face of the commander darkened as he observed the sight beside the queen.

“Your Majesty,” the commander said in a worrying tone, “What do you plan to do now?”

“What else?” A fierce smile hung on her mouth. “I have to fight.”

“However...”

“Then do you wish for me to run away in the face of a threat to our kingdom?”

“Not at all, Your Majesty. However-”

“However?”

“Please forgive me for saying this, but it seems appropriate to retreat and recover from battle,” the guard commander pointed out.

“You are not wrong,” she agreed, “but I see it a bit differently.” She paused before continuing to talk. “There is no way of knowing how the Bone Dragon came to be from a pile of dragon bones and started to move nor what trickery the warlocks used on me after I suppressed them. If there is one thing I know, it is that I am relieved the Bone Dragon wreaked havoc in this garden instead of anywhere else.”

“By relieved, what do you mean, Your Majesty?”

“Imagine what would have happened if the monster ran wild in the capital now.”

“Oh...”

The commander’s face turned as pale as a sheet. The Bone Dragon rampaging the capital where there were tens of thousands of citizens? The thought alone sent chills down his spine.

“So, I must make sure that it stays right here,” Queen Magentano went on. “Until the royal troops are prepared for battle and launch an organized counterattack.”

“Do you mean Your Majesty will personally stall for time?”

“Of course.”

Queen Magentano was looking at him now. Her gaze and facial expression reflected a slight disdain for him for asking such an obvious question.

“Who else, if not me, is a sword master? You? All by yourself?”

“If you order me to, I shall-”

“No, you have proven your worth by staying at my side all this time to protect me,” complimented the queen. “Therefore, it is my turn to prove my own worth.”

“Your worth... Your Majesty? There is no need for you to do so. Your existence alone already-”

“A person who wears the crown to protect their kingdom and people. Is that not the definition of a monarch?”

“...”

“I am simply fulfilling my duty.”

“Y-your Majesty!”

“Shh. I said lower your voice,” ordered the queen.”

“Then... May I join the fight alongside your majesty?”

“That will likely be difficult as you are not a sword master.”

“But my duty and calling is to protect you by your side,” insisted the commander.

“Then your calling for today is to protect your guards. At this rate, they will all die.”

Queen Magentano pointed to the garden with her chin. The guards were struggling to avoid getting trampled under the Bone Dragon’s feet. The face of the commander darkened.

“But my duty is to stay by your side before anything else-”

“This is an order.” Queen Magentano’s voice was firm and definitive.

“Your words are my command...” The commander lowered his head.

Grinning, she replied, “Thank you for understanding my words and for protecting me today. Then I will leave everything to you now.”

“Y-your Majesty!”

“What?” she snapped.

“I dare... pray for you to remain safe.”

“I understand. Well then.”

With that, she was gone.

Rustle. Queen Magentano walked out of the grass. Her movements were completely natural as though there was nothing special about her decision. And she pulled out a sword from her waist without giving time for the commander to stop her and emanated a wave of energy with her whole body.

Fwoosh! Her manaheart raged, and an even more fierce wave of energy circled around her. The commotion was no less than the Bone Dragon’s mana roar that had swept the entire banquet hall.

Kaboom! It was rough yet sharp at the same time and as threatening as a wild predator. The powerful energy prompted Bone Dragon to react at once.

“...”

The Bone Dragon stopped its movement. Queen Magentano lowered her sword. The dragon that came back from death. The human monarch protects her kingdom. The gazes of the two met. Queen Magentano’s body trembled just then.

“...”

Certainly, the dragon was nothing to joke about. The moment she met the Bone Dragon’s gaze, shivers ran down her spine as though she was covered with ice water. That was why she chuckled instead and put on a brave face, repeating the following words in her head.

I am not afraid.

She wasn't confident that she would win. She didn't expect to. But it didn't matter to her. Even if she lost and perished, she vowed that she would at least buy enough time for her kingdom and people to be prepared to protect themselves.

That is why.

She walked toward the Bone Dragon once again without a moment of hesitation.

This is my duty

Failure. Death. None of it scared her. She instead glowered at the Bone Dragon with a calm gaze.

I am a queen.

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Chapter 218: What the Queen Carries (2)

I am a queen.

She lifted her gaze. Under the night sky, the Bone Dragon stood tall like a giant mountain range. An indomitable wall. An impregnable fortress. Could this be what mayfly feels in the presence of a giant?

What a useless worry.

Queen Magentano smiled, and next, she leaped high. *Fwoosh!*

A second later, there was a crater on the spot she jumped from.

Boom! The Bone Dragon's foreleg stabbed the ground, leaving a destructive hole that was 32 feet deep and 82 feet wide upon impact. Rock debris scattered all over the air.

"Hmph!"

Queen Magentano brandished her sword in the air, her sword aura splitting into hundreds of strands that wrapped around her body. Hundreds of rock shards flew at her at a subsonic speed and clashed with her aura.

Clang! Clang! Clang! Sparks flew off from the hundreds of strands wrapped around her. She then broke through the fiery sparks to hurtle toward the Bone Dragon.

Exhale!

As she let out a rough exhale, her manaheart roared, and at the same time, her sword began to change.

Whoosh! The long sword in her hand cried out like a beast, revealing the fangs it had been hiding. Along with a red flash of light, it released an aura that was nearly ten times larger than its blade. Ultimately, the sword created from the aura had a blade that was about 20 inches wide and 13 feet long.

The destructive aura slammed down like an ax, targeting the foreleg of the dragon.

Clatter! She couldn't even make a scratch on the Bone Dragon's skeleton before. But now, it was different.

I did it!

The sword aura created a third of an inch-long crack. A spurt of dark mana power came out from the slightly dented bone.

It wasn't much but it worked.

Her eyes danced with hope. The situation differed from a while ago when none of her attacks worked against the monster. She managed to leave a dent, even if it was a small one, in the Bone Dragon's foreleg. This meant only one thing. If she fought a little harder. If she fought a little better. Then, she could leave more significant damage.

I'm not asking for anything grand. Just one leg. Then the royal troops will be able to put up a fight afterward. I can do it!

Whoosh! Queen Magentano's manaheart roared more ferociously. Now her movement turned rougher and heavier, much like a muscular predator or beast that could snap their prey's neck in one bite. She shifted all her strength against the ground.

Boom! Anything she touched splintered on contact, rocks broke apart and boulders cracked around her. She aggressively walked forward. And with a strong repulsive force, she jumped, her whole body jetting out like a cannonball. Then she concentrated every bit of her massive strength on her sword aura.

"Arggh!"

Crash! With more brute force than technique, Queen Magentano slammed down on the dragon's wrist bone. She hit, slashed, and jabbed him. Then, she repeated the process more fiercely each time.

Boooom! She hurtled toward him five times, which ensued five consecutive explosive attacks. Now, the dent on its carpal bone was slightly deeper. Just then, the Bone Dragon brushed off its wrist.

"...!"

Thwack! Queen Magentano, who was getting ready for the next attack, was grazed by the dragon's movement, sending her to fly 30 yards away. She barely recovered her balance and managed to land safely on the ground.

"Argh...!"

She dry-heaved right after she hit the ground. It was just a small graze. And she had even softened the impact by blocking the blow with her aura sword. But it nearly killed her.

How can it...

Her eyes trembled. Even now, her stomach was churning, and her manaheart struggled to recover from the blow. She suddenly felt bitter.

I had trained so hard, yet…

She didn't take a proper day of rest ever since someone tried to assassinate her. She obsessively spent everyday pushing herself to extreme limits for the sake of training. It was more strenuous than the time she had trained to rise to the level of a sword master. And it made her strong, all right. She could easily win a fight against her past self and Sir Kyle, the man who betrayed her. And that sense of pride had advanced into conviction when she defeated the remaining warlocks.

I thought I had done enough. But...

But she discovered a new height of power that she could never reach. And that was this indomitable monster, Bone Dragon, and it was looking down at her. A shaft of despair gripped her as she looked back up.

I cannot fight it.

In any case, she thought that she could leave a little damage to the dragon and earn enough time for the royal troops to prepare for battle. After all, it was something only she, a swordmaster, could do. That was why she felt the need to take action and was confident of her success. At least, that had been her thought process.

But I was mistaken.

Grit! Queen Magentano clenched her teeth. And she looked up at the Bone Dragon now charging toward her way. Its mouth was open wide, and she raised her aura sword at it. Just then...

Kaboom! A storm of mana flew in one straight line and hit the side of the Bone Dragon's face.

Boooom! Its head was jerked to the side, and the sudden attack managed to stall its hurtle for a short moment. And at that second, she heard a voice.

"Your Majesty, speed over strength. Aim sideways instead of headfirst. I dare to offer my assistance, Your Majesty."

"...!"

Queen Magentano could see it. There was someone in between the clouds that covered the full moon by half. Someone was hurtling through the air, and he landed on the Bone Dragon's backbone and gave a hard stab. Another destructive explosion. The man allowed the force of the explosion to send him flying away, and soon enough, he landed on the queen's side.

"Please forgive me, Your Majesty, but please move over there."

"...!"

It was Javier Asrahan, the silver-haired knight. He was gesturing with his gaze, and Queen Magentano reacted right away. She charged in the direction Javier was pointing to, and the giant mouth of Bone Dragon chewed the very place she was in a second ago.

Crack!

“...”

She dodged and started to counterattack. With Javier joining her, the moment marked the combined attack of two sword masters, a rare event to see in history.

“Your Majesty,” Javier called.

“Yes.”

“May I say a few words?”

“Yes, but drop the formalities, given our current situation. Be as brief as possible,” ordered the queen as she avoided a string of attacks from the Bone Dragon.

“Yes, Your Majesty,” replied Javier as he ran beside her. “Please don’t hold back and jump as high as you can.”

“How about you?”

“I will be its distraction.”

“Distraction?”

“Meaning I will distract the dragon from attacking you. Excuse me, Your Majesty.”

Fwish! Javier disappeared like the wind, and he was already several feet away from her. A light appeared.

Kaboom! A mana blast appeared like a bolt of lightning and struck the very center of the dragon’s backbone. Although it failed to leave any cracks, it was enough to minutely shake the Bone Dragon’s ginormous body. That alone was enough as it gave a slight stagger to the trajectory of the front leg that was coming down on her.

Wham! Its front leg hit the ground after failing to land on Alicia.

All right. I understand his plan.

A ferocious glow appeared in her eyes when she understood Javier's intent. From that moment on, her giant aura sword leaped like a beast, crisscrossing the front and rear legs of the dragon and leaving a scratch on them. But the Bone Dragon couldn’t attack back because of Javier.

Kaboom! Unlike the queen, who could attack only close by, Javier had the mana blast with him. Each time he held out his sword, the mana blast jetted out dozens of feet through the air, striking the gap between its joints each time. And its giant body staggered each time. The reason was simple. Javier capitalized on the vulnerable joints of the body parts that received the weight of its movement. Javier attacked its opposite elbow and wrist when it wielded its foreleg. When it staggered back, Javier attacked its knees and pelvis. And when it attempted to straighten up, he aimed at the back. Each attack was piercing, and the giant body lost balance and reeled, missing its aim at Queen Magentano by a hair’s breadth.

And then the queen would raise her vigor and charge at it without hesitation. She danced with her aura sword while roaring like a ferocious lioness. Meanwhile, her heart sped up by a notch.

This is working. I can do it.

Her heart pounded in hope. She slowly began to see a chance to win. Bone Dragon looked formidable in every sense of the word when she was alone. It was an undefeatable monster. But now, with Javier, she was able to return the dragon’s punches. At the very least, she was able to do something that could be called a fight.

My attack is working!

Her strike didn’t leave great damage. It only left a third of an inch-long crack. That was even after she used all her strength. But if she hit the same spot a hundred times, the crack would become 40 inches long.

40 inches. That’s all we need. The dragon will eventually collapse from its aggressive moments if I drive a 40-inch hole in its wrists and ankles that

hold its massive weight.

The key to fighting a giant mammal was hitting a weight-bearing part of its body. Queen Magentano figured that it would be the same case for Bone Dragon, so she obstinately focused on the wrist connected to its front legs. She threw one blow after another. And finally, she saw a chance for her hopes to turn into reality

A little more. Just a little!

Crash! Slash! Crash! Backed by Javier's support and barely avoiding the Bone Dragon's attack, she whacked the same spot on its body over and over again. Her smile started to grow with her hopes. A faint chance of victory emerged. That was only until Bone Dragon flew high into the air.

Kaboom! Its grand wings spread out without warning. After one rough flap, it was off the ground, right before Queen Magentano could land her hundredth strike. It abruptly swooped into the air. The dragon flew almost 1,000 feet off the ground with a flap of its wings. Queen Megantano lifted her head, her heart swelling with disbelief. It was carefreely flying in the air where she couldn't reach it. And now, it was leisurely looking down at her.

"This cannot be happening..."

She wondered if this was what a colony of ants felt like after failing to capture an eagle with great effort. She wondered if she was in a nightmare.

How am I supposed to fight something like that?

As her gaze darted to the sky and at the Bone Dragon, a despairing sense of helplessness overwhelmed her as if she had been blocked by an impenetrable wall.

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That's it. Keep on despairing. You will feel helpless... Just like how I was...

The Bone Dragon opened its wings, and as it flew up toward the night sky, it gazed down at Queen Magentano, left on the ground by herself. And the

soul in its body, Warlock Targa, thought to himself...

I’m sure I had a similar expression while I was beheaded.

She was looking up at his way, and there was helplessness in her face. It was written with abjection. It was likened to the look of a person in the face of a disastrous natural disaster. That was especially joyful to see for Warlock Targa.

You should be looking at me like that. It’d have been very unfair if I didn’t get to see you making that face.

Targa thought it was unfair. He thought so the moment he was killed in her hands. The warlock was forced to give up on his body in the final moment when his disembodied neck rolled over on the ground. An inevitable choice had to be made. He didn’t want everything to end like this. So, he transferred his soul to the dragon skeleton stored inside the laboratory. It was his last resort or final act of desperation, to put it one way.

He hadn’t had high hopes to begin with. His chance of success was less than ten percent. But it worked. His soul was transferred into the skeleton of the dragon. That was the moment he gave up on being a human. From then, there was a long period of waiting. He used the time to wait for his soul to settle into the dragon skeleton. It took a few months. And finally, the day had come. Today. Targa opened his eyes to a new body, and the result was better, beyond his expectation.

I didn’t expect to hold this much strength.

He turned out to be very strong. Though he wasn’t as powerful as the actual Bone Dragon, a simple imitation was all that he could manifest, still, he was powerful enough to toy the queen like a bug. What was more, he could do so even when he wasn’t used to the body at all!

I’m *done warming up now.*

Targa smiled ferociously, determined that this was the end of the monotonous attack with forelegs. It was time to get real and toy the queen

hard. He focused on the alienating sensation of fluttering the wings. That got his body to fly higher in the air. The grand garden and the palace behind it, the city district, everything felt like a toy, a city of the bugs. And at the same time, he even felt he had become omnipotent. In a word, he felt like he was...

I feel like I've become a god.

He was thrilled. Everything seemed doable. He wanted to crush every creature that stood in his way.

Queen Magentano in particular. How dare you behead me. You will pay the price for your actions. I will slaughter you until you're at the edge of death and make you watch the capital completely collapse in flames.

The soul of the Bone Dragon, Targa, smirked in an evil way. Now, the fluttering of wings felt natural. The time has come to knuckle down and smash things. The time for enjoyment has come. The time to break and kill everything in sight.

Wahaha!

It lowered its giant head and closed its wings for a dive. But when it was about to, an unexpected creature took a nosedive at it first.

"Ggoming!"

Swooosh!

Huh...?

A white form zoomed down through the murky clouds like a bolt of lightning. It was chubby and had wings. A round head and clear eyes. So this was...

A parrotbill?

But it was larger than a human. Its shape felt familiar. Just then, Targa recalled the story he had heard right after their schemes failed in Namaran.

A report from a guy said that there was a man who attacked them on the parrotbill. The man’s name was...

Lloyd Frontera?

Targa remembered. That was when Lloyd yelled as he dove with Ggoming and threw something toward it.

“First, take this!”

Fwish! Something was flying his way. Targa saw an ordinary beaver flying toward his way. He felt flustered.

“...”

What now? What is this Lloyd doing by hurling that beaver in this situation? Right when Targa was dumbstruck...

Boom!

“...”

The beaver suddenly turned gigantic, his body grew to be 328 feet tall. And swaying his merciless belly, Bibeong pulled the dragon into a hug right away.

“Bibeong!”

Eh?!

Bibeong got it in his embrace in mere seconds. And now, Bibeong laid a body-press attack against the Bone Dragon midair 8,200 feet off the ground, pressing it with his 3,000-ton body.

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Chapter 219: Smack the Head and Run (1)

“Bibeong!”

8,200 feet off the sky of the Magentano palace, Bibeong distantly shouted aloud. Then he grabbed the Bone Dragon’s spine and rib bone. *Clench!*

The Bone Dragon had nothing but bones left in its body, so Bibeong had plenty of areas to grip. Though his hands couldn’t grip as well as a human’s, the Bone dragon’s entire body was essentially a handle for him.

Eh?

The soul of warlock Targa in the Bone Dragon was flabbergasted.

What is this?

Targa was flustered. And dumbstruck. What just happened? A guy on a parrotbill flitted his way out of the blue and hurled a beaver, which slammed into him after growing 328 feet tall. Anyone would snort at him if he told them this story. Heck, if someone else told him such an outrageous story, Targa would have yelled at them to shut up and cursed the person with black magic. That was how ridiculous the whole thing was to him. But unfortunately, that ludicrous event was happening now. Thus, he was tightly trapped in Bibeong’s grip.

“Bibeobeong!”

Bibeong struggled, tightening his embrace around the Bone Dragon. He leaned against the back of the dragon as he tensed his chubby butt and belly, pressing his wing joint. That severely interrupted its fluttering.

A-Argh! Let me go! Surprised, Targa gave a delayed response. He twisted and turned to wrench Bibeong off of himself. But he was stronger than Targa thought. That was thanks to Bibeong’s weight.

This punk is a lot heavier than I thought!

Targa believed that he would be heavier. The Bone Dragon's body was 656 feet long, which was almost twice the length of Bibeong. So, Targa naturally thought that his weight must be heavier than this beaver. But what he missed was their interior anatomy which was another different story.

Is this beaver heavier than me?

That was when it dawned on Targa. The Bone Dragon had nothing in its body but bones, so it was super scrawny compared to its gigantic size. Moreover, its tail made up a good portion of the length of its body.

Whereas Bibeong, was fat. Chubby buttocks. Flabby belly. Ample cheeks. Every part of him was fat and flabby. On top of that, the muscles that bore the sheer weight of his fats were solid and thick. In short, there was no way for the Bone Dragon, despite its dragon-thick bones, to outweigh Bibeong's limitless fats. Bibeong cuddled the Bone Dragon and pressed its wing joint with his monumental weight and belly fat. That brought a stop to its fluttering. And thus, it began to crash down.

"Bibeong!"

Ackkk!

8,200 feet off the ground. The Bone Dragon turned its long head and attempted to bite Bibeong, who was on its back. Bibeong ducked down and used his giant front teeth to fiercely bite down on its neck bone.

"Bibebeong!"

Gargh!

4,200 feet off the ground. Bone Dragon wielded its whip-like tail and smacked Bibeong's back. Bibeong fought back by whipping with his flat tail, which was wide and flat like a giant roe, the perfect shape to protect his whole body. The Bone Dragon's tail bounced off Bibeong's shield-like tail.

"Bibeong!"

Arggh!

1,640 feet off the ground. Sensing the crash, the Bone Dragon attempted one final attack to turn things around. It tensed its whole body to flip its body upside down. But it didn’t work. There was no other reason for its failure. Bibeong was too fat to be turned over. So the Bone Dragon was pressed toward the ground, slammed in the air by 3,000-ton weight, and plummeted. No brakes or anything.

“Bibebeong!”

Daaammit!!!

“…!”

They hit the ground without a single shout. Everyone who gazed at the whole scene thought for a second that the ground had flipped over. The impending roar, earth tremor, and storm of sand arrived in the next moment.

Kaboom! As 4,000 tons of total weight rammed into the land with massive kinetic energy, the whole ground shook, and shockwaves burst all around, toppling the trees nearby. The royal guards covered their ears to protect their eardrums.

“Get down!”

“Argh...!”

The dusty storm faded sometime later, and the guards staggered to their feet in a coughing fit. Among them was Queen Magentano, whose eyes shone brightly.

“...”

She wasn’t staring at the crash location like the rest of the guards. Instead, her deathly gaze flickered over to the large parrotbill in the air, whose vague outline could be seen through the thick dust.

Lloyd Frontera.

She remembered how he had run for his life when she called. The sight utterly disappointed her. But now, a part of her wondered if he had intentionally run away to do this.

Tsk. What a mysterious fellow he is.

Queen Magentano chuckled. It was a relief nonetheless. She had been utterly clueless about how she should deal with the Bone Dragon. A sense of hopelessness gripped her, but thankfully, Lloyd showed up just in time and did something extraordinary with his fantastical creature.

That large fantastical creature crushed the Bone Dragon all the way in the air.

The queen's gaze moved toward the crash point. She believed that the Bone Dragon couldn't have remained intact after falling down at such a height. No, she even suspected the dragon might have been completely subdued just now. She was starting to become hopeful when...

Ruuumble...!

Something giant rose amid the thick sandy dust. A gray outline of a jagged skeleton appeared. It was the Bone Dragon.

"...!"

Whoosh! A giant tail swept the surface.

"Argh!"

Queen Magentano jumped just in time and closely avoided the attack. But the next one that followed seemed unavoidable. The dragon's gigantic, open wing swung across the whole area. *Whoosh!*

She clenched her teeth. There was no way to avoid or block the attack.

Then I only have one choice!

Goosebumps rose all over her body as she gripped the sword hilt. She decided to confront the incoming blow head-on. Even if this was her last moment, she resolved to combat valiantly until she died. Thus, she wielded her sword with such determination. But before she could actually do so, someone grabbed the back of her neck and tugged hard.

“Your Majesty!”

Grab!

“...!”

She felt someone grab the back of her neck and heard a voice. Frightened, she withdrew her sword and turned around. Then she saw who it was.

“Lloyd Frontera?”

Lloyd had gripped her collar with one hand while using the other to hold a riding rein. She also spotted the large parrotbill that Lloyd was riding frantically fluttering his wings. Just like that, she was saved in midair by Lloyd and Ggoming.

“Y-Your Majesty! Stop flailing!” Lloyd bellowed, almost threatening to let go of his grip if she continued to struggle.

The queen obeyed his words and relaxed. Her gaze then darted to the gigantic menacing wings that chased toward them. *Fwoosh!*

My...

Could this be what a fly saw while looking at an incoming fly swatter? The dragon’s huge wing which was the size of a cliff hurtled toward her way, sweeping across her entire range of vision like a broom. The scene itself made her heart drop. But to her relief, she was at the mercy of a mobile creature that could avoid such an attack.

“Ggoming!”

“A little more! Ggoming! Let’s goooo!” yelled Lloyd.

“Ggomiiing!!!”

Ggoming fluttered his wings at a maddening speed, and the explosive acceleration allowed them to distance themselves from the incoming wing. Just then, the parrotbill closed his wings and dove down in a flash, almost touching the ground. *Swooosh!*

The expansive wing bone passed over her head with a proximity of less than 3 feet. Taking a deep breath as though she was shaking off her shivers, Queen Alicia got back on the parrotbill.

“Your Majesty, are you hurt?” asked Lloyd.

“No. Thank you. I owe you my life.”

“That is a relief,” said Lloyd.

Lloyd really felt that way. He genuinely was relieved that she didn’t die.

It would be troublesome if the queen died.

Queen Magentano was his boss that always had more work to give him. But at the same time, she was his most reliable supporter and contact. She didn’t accuse him of treason for most things and showered his fiefdom with all sorts of assistance.

It’s really not easy to meet and serve a boss like her.

She surely was the ideal ruler to serve, disregarding her tendency to swamp him with work. So, losing her would be a loss for Lloyd. There was no guarantee that the new monarch after her would be favorable to him.

The queen can’t die here. This applies to Javier as well.

Lloyd surveyed the ground as he led Ggoming outside the sphere of the attack. The Bone Dragon was going berserk, whereas Bibeong was staggering, probably due to the body-press attack. Lloyd passed by and pulled on Javier in a flash. But it was too early to be relieved.

Here comes the important part. Speed is critical.

He would run away with the queen and Javier. His first priority was safely escaping. That was the reason Lloyd came here.

“Then let’s go!” yelled Lloyd proudly.

“Where?” the queen asked right away.

Wetting his lips, Lloyd shouted, “To a better battlefield!”

“A new battlefield?” asked the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty. This area is not suitable for a battle since this garden is new, and the palace, city district, and people are nearby!”

When Lloyd gave the remark he had prepared, the queen reacted positively to his relief.

“Lloyd Frontera. Are you worried about the well-being of innocent citizens who could be affected by this affliction?”

“Yes, Your Majesty!”

“Good. You are right. Then do you plan on drawing the monster out of the capital?”

“You are right, Your Majesty!”

“Good. I approve of your plan.”

“I am overwhelmed-”

“There is no time to be overwhelmed. Hurry up,” interrupted the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty!”

Lloyd was relieved that the queen gave her approval. Deciding to make his plan a success, Lloyd grabbed his reins.

“Ggoming!” Lloyd called.

“Ggoming?”

“Let’s gooo!”

“Ggomiming!”

His flight speed increased, and Lloyd threw a glance at the Bone Dragon.

Okay. Everything is going according to plan.

The queen had given her trust. And now, it was time to knuckle down and execute his plan.

That is, for us to run without looking back.

Far away. Far away outside the capital. Farther out. Somewhere very far where a battle could take place. If possible, he intended to fly away for about three days straight.

Fight? Why should we fight that thing? We should just keep running away.

In actuality, Lloyd didn’t plan on fighting against the Bone Dragon head-on. He planned on playing tag with it just like now.

And if possible, I’ll fly outside the border to a place far, far away from the capital. That way the people in the capital and the queen will be safe.

That was his plan. Moreover, if he was lucky, he might be able to take care of the Bone Dragon too. How?

To Gapel. That’s where we should go. I heard that something more formidable than the Bone Dragon lives there.

Just then, the entity that was briefly mentioned in the novel came to his mind. The Gapel region. A seemingly ordinary and small neutral county. However, an extraordinary creature was said to be inhabiting there.

His name was Verkis. He was the Dragon King, if I recall correctly?

Dragon King Verkis. The history book of the Lorasia Continent made a mention of him as the most powerful dragon to ever exist. The novel touched on it as a mere rumor just once, and that was it. That was why Lloyd had forgotten about this matter until now. It was a miracle that he happened to recall this just today.

But that is enough.

Lloyd decided to put his trust in the story in the novel. Dragon King. He was the dragon king, for Pete's sake! Being the king, this mythical dragon would be interested in the affairs of dragons, and he would be a faithful and hardworking figure.

So, taking the Bone Dragon that's running amuck would be the same as taking a zombie or skeleton soldier to a human king. With that, the situation will naturally resolve itself. I mean, he's the Dragon King. He won't sit back and just watch the Bone Dragon go berserk. I presume he'd look sideways and order for the Bone Dragon to be taken care of. Or, maybe, he'd take care of it himself.

Lloyd had a feeling that this king would straighten the situation out.

And I don't care if my plan fails either.

The rumor could be false. It was possible that the Dragon King was not there. But Lloyd concluded that it didn't matter.

Then I can opt for plan B, which is leading the Bone Dragon to an unpopulated area.

That would complete their escape. Of course, the Bone Dragon would return in the future. But they would be better prepared than now as the chase between the dragon and Lloyd toward Gapel would buy them some time to respond.

It takes about three days to fly to Gapel. While we were flying, the news would spread to the capital and throughout the whole kingdom. The sultan kingdom and other nearby nations would hear about it too.

Then everyone would be able to brace themselves and assemble strong forces to fight against the Bone Dragon's invasion. That would be a much more organized response than the queen's solo confrontation with her sword.

That's how I can buy more time. It would also be more advantageous for us by any standard. So, why risk ourselves and fight here? We should obviously leave!

His judgment couldn't be any more reasonable and wiser. Satisfied with his plan, he prompted Ggoming to flutter harder before throwing a glance at the Bone Dragon's side. Lloyd decided that he had to attract its attention so that it would be engulfed in rage and hot on his heels. He needed to make the dragon obstinately pursue him for multiple days on end.

"Javier, your sword, please."

Lloyd borrowed a long sword from Javier and stretched his sword at the Bone Dragon as he flew around it on the ground.

Boom! A triple mana blast came out of the sword, which flew across for several yards and hit the back of the Bone Dragon head.

Clung! The Bone Dragon's skull staggered at the sudden blow.

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Chapter 220: Smack the Head and Run (2)

Clung! Getting smacked in the back of the head was annoying. The simple sensation of your head bumping into something was distasteful in the first place. And it was particularly the case if that smack reminded you of the moment of your death.

A triple mana blast flew out of nowhere and knocked the Bone Dragon's skull. As it reeled from the impact, Targa gritted his teeth in its body. He had been intoxicated for a second from obtaining the sheer power of the Bone Dragon, feeling as though he became a god. But all of a sudden, his mood turned sour. The moment of his death came to his mind.

It was like this that time...

He had been beheaded. The back of his head landed on the ground with a thud and rolled away. How chilling it was when his head rolled on the ground! Targa desperately wanted to forget that sensation now that he was in his new body. But he couldn't. And he was reminded of it just now because of the bastard who left a sharp blow to his head.

The Bone Dragon lifted its head, and Lloyd came into its view. And when it saw him fly with the parrotbill, it was reminded once again of what happened.

Namaran.

Targa's botched plan in Namaran came to his mind. He had planned to summon Hell's Knight by offering the people there as a sacrifice. One month was enough time for Hell's Knight to wipe out the kingdom and the major cities and forces. But he had failed. And because of who?

That bastard.

It must have been right after his plan failed. He had received a report from an informant he planted in Namaran. It mentioned that someone excavated and stole all his Noctanium, the black stone he processed with the mana

extracted from the bone of the Bone Dragon. Moreover, he was told that someone on a parrotbill slaughtered the warlocks on the day of the event. And when Hell's Knight woke up, the same man killed it alongside a knight with silver hair.

Lloyd Frontera.

Targa recalled his name. But Namaran wasn't the only time that the man interfered with his plans.

He also blocked the assassination of the queen.

The poison he used was acquired after an immense struggle on his part. And it had been even more difficult to recruit Sir Kyle, the sword master. When Targa acquired both, he pushed forward with his scheme, convinced his plan was perfect and would bring chaos to the House of Magentano. But it ended in failure. And the fault lay in Lloyd Frontera.

If it weren't for you...

All of his schemes would have succeeded. At least, things wouldn't have ended up in absolute disaster like now. Queen Magentano would have either died or become crippled. Her throne would have toppled, and her control over the kingdom's regions would have weakened. Hell's Knight would have awakened amid that instability, and the 500 undead Mastodons would have caused an uproar near the Frontera fiefdom. Hell's Knight and 500 undead Mastodons. The two would have been enough to wipe out an entire kingdom. On top of that, Targa had one last final touch in mind that would vouch for the success of his aspirations: a plague that turned people into zombies and the cure for it.

If I succeeded...

An innumerable number of people would have been zombified. The curse would have spread like an epidemic, and since it was a curse finished with a special procedure, even the high temple officials' blessing couldn't treat it. The only method of cure was the medicine produced by the mana extracted from the Bone Dragon's bone. In other words, Targa made his plan, so that

he’d be the only one who could cure the zombies. He’d emerge as a messiah after the fall of the royal family, the whole region was set aflame, and the whole kingdom became zombified. That was his plan.

If things took place that way...

He could have become the king. An emperor even. But now, it was impossible. He was dead. Though he could run riot, he was no longer a human. And there was no way to go back to being a human.

Now, I’m nothing but a monster.

He had wanted to rise above his position and rule over the world. How he had yearned to be the object of fear and respect! He had dreamed of discarding his discriminating label of warlock and becoming a dictator remembered all throughout history!

But I can’t anymore.

Even if he held the power of a god now, his wish couldn’t be achieved anymore. All his plans failed, and now, he was nothing but a monster.

It’s all because of you.

Fire burned in his eyes as he glared at Lloyd. Murderous desire rose in him. That emotion brought a change to the Bone Dragon. No, it brought a big change to Targa inside the Bone Dragon.

I’m going to kill you. I don’t know about the others, but you’re dead.

Kaboom! The Bone Dragon spread its wings. There was no more awkwardness in its gait or fluttering. The body of the dragon he was in no longer felt unfamiliar, and Targa didn’t even think about taking more time to adapt. He simply decided to fly upward, rip apart, destroy, and chomp down on everything in sight. He’d burn and trample on everything until it became a pile of ash and his rage was quenched.

Boom! Kaboom! The Bone Dragon leaped high. One jump. That alone propelled it 2600 feet off the ground. Then it spread out its wings. The

space between its empty joints was set ablaze and harnessed an explosive power with the flaps of its wings.

Thwack! Just once. Its wings fluttered once and pushed on the surrounding air. One flap of its wings, and the air swirled around it. The air was explosively pushed away and compressed, creating a shockwave that sent the dragon's 656-foot body flying straight forward for hundreds of yards.

Fwoosh! The Bone Dragon zoomed forward in a flash, and his large skull became the peak that overlapped the airwave. It overlapped, amplified, and finally exploded in a burst of shock.

Wham! A powerful sonic boom was created as the air condensed around it. The windows of the palace and nearby buildings got shattered. Everyone in the garden covered their ears and collapsed.

"What the... That's nuts!"

Lloyd, too, wanted to collapse. He stared behind, goggle-eyed. The Bone Dragon was hurtling toward him as it neared the distance, and it looked like it was hell-bent on knocking him out!

How can it be so fast?!

Lloyd was gobsmacked. His plan was to run away, and that was why he smacked its nape with the triple mana blast to provoke it to be on his heels. But it never occurred to Lloyd that it would pursue him at a shocking speed and fling itself at him so thoughtlessly and deathly.

Maybe it's the type of dragon that hates getting smacked in the head?

But none of that mattered right now. Because right now, even in that split second of thought, the Bone Dragon flapped its wings once more. A sonic boom commenced as air moved around and water vapors appeared.

Wham! The distance between them became worryingly close.

I'm going to get caught.

Five seconds? Four? No, less than that. What could happen to Lloyd if he got caught?

Well, no point in wondering! It'd be the same as a puppy getting crashed from behind by a fully-speeding tank.

Every bone of his would be broken. Lloyd's eyes trembled when he imagined it. The response he gave was immediate.

"Ggoming! Down!" yelled Lloyd.

"Ggoming!"

Ggoming, too, had been feeling the charge of a dangerous figure from behind, so he immediately closed his wings as soon as he heard Loyd's shout. He then did his specialty in flying, a sudden drop.

"Ggomiming!"

Ggoming lowered his head, shot downward like a nimble sparrow, and let gravity drop him vertically.

Argh!

The headwind blew like a storm, and Lloyd held on as he grabbed the saddle.

Could it still be following me?

Lloyd threw a glance behind.

It's following me...!

The color drained from Lloyd's face. The Bone Dragon was right behind him, its lowered head and closed wings much like Ggoming. It was nimbly swooping down, hot on his heels!

"Come on... Ggoming! Move left!" bawled Lloyd in desperation.

“Ggoming!”

At Lloyd’s urgent yelling, Ggoming turned his head to the left and rotated like a nail screw 720 degrees counterclockwise. And he then swiveled 90 degrees to the left, using the twist as his propulsion. That got him in horizontal flight mode. Right after that, the Bone Dragon did exactly the same and maneuvered exactly the same flight like a swallow with its giant body. What was more, it even stretched its giant neck!

Chomp! The Bone Dragon chomped the very space Ggoming was at a second ago, and its large teeth almost bit his tail.

“Ggoming! Ggomiming!”

Ggoming cried out urgently, hurrying Lloyd to come up with something as he couldn’t do anything more and was just seconds before getting caught.

“I know! I know!”

Lloyd’s forehead broke out in a cold sweat, and he was forced to admit that he had planned it too comfortably on this one.

I made a mistake this time. I should have run away without looking back, without giving a hoot about the others.

Lloyd didn’t care if people hurled insults at him for being a coward. They may call him trash, but Lloyd didn’t care. What mattered more was staying alive.

But, come on! Why did I come back to save Javier and the queen?!

Lloyd regretted the decision he had made ten minutes ago.

Am I really going to die here?

Lloyd was at a loss. He felt dejected. Ggoming was flying to his best, and Ggoming was the best mobile asset Lloyd had. But that Bone Dragon showed no signs of that awkwardness in its movement that was evident a while ago. It was likened to a supersonic fighter jet or a rocket. It was flying

at a scary speed, tearing up the whole air. And not with its tremendous body, it boasted outrageous mobility that of a sparrow. No, it was more fitting to say that the Bone Dragon was a skyscraper flying like a dragonfly.

I can't run away from it.

Not a single method to lose this dragon, who was well-skilled in flying, came to Lloyd's mind. The mere possibility of it was hard to imagine. But Lloyd didn't give up.

No. I'm going to die if I give up. So think. Work, my brain!

Lloyd desperately racked his brain as he led Ggoming to perform various acrobatic flights and came close to losing his life at the attack of the Bone Dragon. He didn't want to die here. He had to make it out of here alive, come hell or high water. The desire to live increased when he recalled the comfortable life he had dutifully toiled for in the Frontera fiefdom.

And so, he beat his brains for his life, scavenging every piece of information stashed in his head. The setting of the novel. The history he had changed. The littlest events took place a few months ago. And at last...

Oh, hold on.

Something came up. Lloyd lifted his head and swiveled.

I need to check first!

There was no time to lose. The Bone Dragon was charging at full speed with its giant body. Starting right into the monster, Lloyd inwardly shouted...

Surveying!

He tensed his eyes and glared at the Bone Dragon.

Bzzt!

[Scanning will begin.]

Every part of its body came into view along with the familiar message. But Lloyd didn’t study its whole body.

But I don’t have time for this!

His gaze darted to the lower part of its body. In between the frenzied chase, Lloyd spotted its tail that appeared from time to time. The giant tail was constantly moving left and right to ensure balance in its flight.

So, please...! Come on! Show yourself!

Lloyd’s desperate eyes ran along its tail from the end, from the thinnest part to the middle part that thickened in size. And at last, around one-third of its tail...

Found it!

A ray of hope appeared in Lloyd’s eyes. He found it. He could see it. The chunk of tailbone he was looking for. To be more exact, it was...

A fake tailbone!

The area Lloyd was looking at. A section of its tailbone was different from the rest. To be more exact, it was not a bone. It was granite. Why? The reason was simple.

Because you see, I took the actual bone. That was my payment for working for the queen!

A few months ago, around the time the Termina Garden project took off, he informed the installation expert in charge of the dragon project in advance that the chunk of the tailbone was his and that it must be left aside.

Then I totally forgot about it because I was so busy with the garden and cleaning up today’s mess.

But now that he remembered and checked, the chunk of its tailbone was missing from the skeleton and filled with a rock.

What's more, we used granite to cut the material cost!

Lloyd recalled how the palace wanted to use the expensive backbone of the emperor whale. Though it was not as fancy as the dragon bone, it boasted remarkable strength and was lightweight. But there was one problem.

It was too expensive.

It wasn't just expensive. It was obscenely expensive, the kind that increases the material cost a whopping amount for no useful reason. So Lloyd himself stopped the palace by convincing them that no one was going to study the dragon bone with a magnifying glass. People would go wow on their cruise ship. So what must be done instead was sculpting the rock to have similar color and texture as the dragon bone. The rock needed to be strong just enough to ensure that the skeleton won't fall apart, and granite will do those jobs just fine. He argued and set his foot down.

That was how I lowered the cost of materials!

Though the money came from the palace, he didn't want to waste the money on something unnecessary. That was why he stubbornly protested against the possible squandering of material costs. At that time, it never occurred to Lloyd that it would be this helpful. No, it never, ever occurred to Lloyd that the rock would become the only weakness he could capitalize on. An evil smile appeared on Lloyd's smile.

"Excuse me! I have an idea!" Lloyd yelled at the people behind him. "But you know, we fail, and this will be our graveyard! So! Any last words?!"

"..."

No response came. So, Lloyd turned around and looked back.

Dang. What's wrong with their faces?

The queen and Javier put on overly dramatic faces. They looked like they were ready to die in a grand but daunting battle.

The sight of their faces made Lloyd let out a snort. The two appeared to be extremely tense, and since nothing looked like his words would be deafened out, Lloyd decided to sober them up. That was the only way they'd give their ears to his plan. With a resolved heart and determination, Lloyd prepared a load of truth bombs.

"Then I'll go first!" yelled Lloyd. "Javier! It was fun to be with you, but I hate you! You boast every day that you get a lot of love letters. But you know what? You're single just like me! And Your Majesty! No. Sister!"

"What...? Me?" gaped the queen.

"Yeah, Sister! You too! I hate you a little too! You always excitedly exploit me!"

"Did you dare call me, Sister, just now?" asked the queen defiantly.

"Who cares about that when we're going to die anyway soon?"

"You-"

"Anyway! Now it looks like you all are relaxed a little!"

Lloyd cut off the queen and shouted aloud again.

"From now on, listen to what I say, and please follow me! This one is, you see! We succeed, and we'll be able to live! And forgive me for calling you sister a while ago! And exempt me from labor for ten years! And really, just if... If I catch the Bone Dragon! Give all the bones to me! Do you agree?!"

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Chapter 221: Smack the Head and Run (3)

“Do you agree?!”

“What?” The queen’s eyebrow trembled. She doubted if she heard him right.

Bestow all of the dragon bones to him? And not enough with that, exempt him from ten years of labor?

Queen Magentano was dumbstruck and couldn’t believe what she just heard. But there wasn’t any time to argue. She quickly scanned her eyes behind herself.

Chomp! About 10 feet behind her, the Bone Dragon aggressively chomped down its jaw once again. If things went wrong, they would be no different from a beetle that had been crushed by a door hinge. There wasn’t any time to hesitate or think.

Lloyd Frontera, you are using this opportunity to be granted an exorbitant request. But...

Giving everything he wanted was better than getting killed here. The queen made a flash judgment and gave her decision without a second thought.

“All right. I approve,” she spoke aloud.

“Really, Your Majesty?!”

“Indeed.”

“Then do you mean that you shall exempt me from labor for the next ten years and give me all of the dragon bones?” asked Lloyd again.

“Indeed.”

“Duly noted. As a neutral party here, Javier Asrahan will stand as the witness to your words! Do you agree, Your Majesty?”

“I said, I do!” huffed the queen in annoyance.

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

Chomp! Once again, the Bone Dragon bit down his jaw in a close distance.

“Then! Please listen carefully to my plan!” Lloyd pointed to the back of the Bone Dragon’s body. “Look over there! You will see that the 19th tailbone is slightly different from the other surrounding parts!”

“The 19th tailbone?”

“Yes, Your Majesty!”

Queen Magentano and Javier’s gaze traveled to the 19th tailbone. But they failed to notice anything different.

“Strange,” the queen remarked. “To me, they all look the same in both shape and material.”

“No, Your Majesty!” Lloyd answered with conviction before making a big confession. “In actuality, Your Majesty! That is not a piece of bone but granite!”

“What...? Granite?”

“Yes, Your Majesty! Do you recall how Your Majesty promised to bestow me a chunk of the dragon’s tailbone?”

“Yes, I do!” answered the queen. “However, did you not report to me that you planned on using the spine of an emperor whale, not granite? You said it was an excellent replacement due to its impressive durability and quality.”

“Your Majesty is correct!”

“But what happened?” Queen Magentano wondered why the fake bone was made of granite, not the backbone of the emperor whale.

“The backbone of the emperor whale was too expensive!” Lloyd yelled another confession.

“...”

“As such, I argued to use granite instead and pushed forward with it!”

“...”

“When we cut and refined the granite, it was exactly the same. It would be difficult to distinguish between the dragon’s tailbone and the granite with the naked eye! Right now, even Your Majesty could not tell the difference between the two! What was more, I thought it was a better option since the granite was one-tenth of the cost of the emperor whale’s backbone!”

“You wouldn’t have dared to embezzle the leftover money, am I right?” shot back the queen at Lloyd.

“Not at all, Your Majesty!”

Lloyd quickly shook his head. He really didn’t pocket the leftover money and simply reduced the price of the construction.

“The dragon skeleton was only meant to be admired from a distance! I judged that it is more efficient to use granite since it looks the same to the naked eye and holds enough durability to support the overall skeleton structure! I believed that the money saved here could be used for a better purpose in the future!”

Lloyd was genuine about this. Though the palace’s finances weren’t his business, he hated wasting money on a construction project. If there was another alternative with the same function, safety, and aesthetics as his initial choice in material, and was a mere one percent of its cost, Lloyd figured that it was more economical to use the cheaper option. That was why he insisted on using the granite and went on with it.

“That is why, Your Majesty! The decision I made back then! It will become the key to destroying this dragon!”

Chomp! About six feet behind, the Bone Dragon chomped down its jaw once again. While their conversation was taking place, Ggoming relentlessly flew up and down. Like a fly desperately trying to lose a giant eagle, Ggoming flew until his wings were drenched in sweat.

“I personally think,” Lloyd went on to shout, “that the 19th prosthetic tailbone is receiving the effects of the mana power that maintains the dragon’s body!”

“I agree. That must explain how it can move with such coordination with the other joints,” seconded the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty. It must also mean that it will be much harder than most other pieces of granite.”

“And yet, it will be weaker compared to the other bones,” said the queen, understanding his point.

“That truly is the case, Your Majesty!” beamed Lloyd. “What is more! If that bone is shattered, the whole tail will snap off and the dragon won’t be able to fly anymore like now!”

What Lloyd said was obvious. The tail wasn’t a decorative one. It was an indispensable organ, more so when it came to flight.

It allows the dragon to maintain balance!

But once the tail was lost, the Bone Dragon would drop after losing balance and wouldn’t be able to fly again, much like an aircraft with a lost tail wing.

Then my original plan to use the dragon king won’t work anymore. So, this is my best option for now. It’s better than getting our heads crushed and becoming one with nature after being caught by the Bone Dragon.

Choose an effective strike instead of immediate death. What comes next can be sketched out later.

Thinking so, Lloyd hurriedly shouted,” Therefore! I will become a bait!”

“You will?” asked the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty!”

The queen’s eyes widened. Javier’s eyebrow trembled.

Lloyd smiled wryly as he looked at both of them. “Who among us can fly better with Ggoming in harmony but me?”

That was a fact.

“Therefore, I will become its bait and draw its attention. Meanwhile, please crush its 19th tailbone.”

Lloyd put his hand into his pocket and brought out Ppodong and Bangul.

“These kids will be your help.”

“Ppodong!”

“Bangul!”

Lloyd fed the red sunflower seed to Ppodong and Bangul, whose eyes were glimmering. And he threw them toward the ground, each of them growing large with a boom and landing safely on the ground.

“Please get down now!” urged Lloyd.

“...”

Even until then, Queen Magentano stared at Lloyd without saying anything. Lloyd smiled, only a corner of his mouth rising.

“Your Majesty, we do not have much time. Please hurry,” urged Lloyd again.

“Then you-”

“Please do not worry about me.”

“No,” she said as she shook her head. “I am not worried about you. I am simply stupefied that you just revealed your usage of the granite in place of the emperor whale’s backbone just now.”

“...”

“Had this not happened, you would have never said anything, right?” pointed out the queen.

“...”

“Technically speaking, that is obviously an act of embezzlement-”

“I pray you to be safe, Your Majesty!”

Urgent, Lloyd reined to flip Ggoming upside down, and the unexpected turn caused the queen and Javier to dangle from their saddle. They then let go of their grips as there was no time for argument.

Ten years of labor exemption? Do you dare think you can slip out of my hands so easily? It is easy to tie you down. I simply have to ask you to choose between the punishment of embezzling or discarding the labor exemption.

But now, survival and preventing that awful disaster in the capital came first. The wry smile on her face vanished as she landed on the ground. And now, her eyes shone with determination. Javier, who landed beside her, nodded. They had a momentary exchange of eyes. That was enough for these two sword masters.

Sprint! Each ran in the opposite direction as they passed through the shrubs, where a fantastical creature waited in each place.

“Sir Ppodong, nice to meet you.”

“Ppodong!”

Javier got on Ppodong’s plump back, and the latter started to zoom off. On the other end of the waterway, the queen met Bangul.

“Is your name Bangul?” the queen asked.

“Bangul!”

“My memory is right,” she said. “I look forward to fighting with you.”

“Bba-bangul! Bangul!”

The queen got on Bangul’s back. And the latter started to gulp the water in the waterway. And she wagged her tail very earnestly. *Jingle! Jingle!*

She alerted the surrounding with her melodious warning, and the moment she lifted her tail, a massive explosion burst from her buttock.

Gurgle! Rumble!

Bangul quickly digested the water she drank. A large amount of boiling steam jetted out of her like an explosive volcano. *Kaboom!*

Steam shot out of her with incredible pressure, and Bangul glided through the waterway like a motor banana boat. The queen lifted her sword on top of her.

Lloyd Frontera.

Her gaze moved upward toward the night sky. Ggoming and Lloyd were frantically flying about in a desperate effort to run away from the Bone Dragon that was madly chasing after them.

I do not wish to lose you.

An excellent subject. A reliable worker. But at the same time, a man she was immensely grateful toward. She didn’t wish to lose Lloyd Frontera in a place like this.

Never.

Clench! The back of her hand that gripped the sword tightened. Meanwhile, Javier was making a similar resolution as the queen.

Master Lloyd.

He was sprinting across the garden riding Ppodong, and his gaze was fixed on Lloyd above.

I had no idea that this was your plan, Master Lloyd.

Javier bit his underlip. Once again, he had another misunderstanding. He was wrong to think that Master Lloyd would be someone who ran away in this kind of situation, a pathetic coward who fled to survive all by himself. Javier realized that he was too rash in judging his young master that way.

This happened in Cremo too.

He remembered how he had harshly expressed his disappointment in Master Lloyd, saying he wasn't aware of his rotten character.

It's the same today.

Javier realized that he was the foolish one. Lloyd was the type of man who was always ready to sacrifice himself.

So... I will protect you, so you will not have to sacrifice yourself.

Clench! Javier made a resolve in his heart. He would push aside his own safety if it meant protecting his young master. He wouldn't stand back even at the risk of his own life.

You must remain safe no matter what, Young Master.

Wishing so, Javier encouraged Ppodong to ride faster. Meanwhile, Lloyd was struggling by himself.

Huff! Queen! Javier! Hurry up a little!

Chomp! The Bone Dragon bit down right behind him. Chills ran down Lloyd's spine. One wrong move and he was sure to get crushed.

But... this is still doable!

The queen and Javier left, so that was one less thing for him to worry about. Ggoming's movements became slightly more relaxed.

All right. I just need to keep running away like now!

Thankfully, the Bone Dragon had its eyes on Lloyd and nothing else. It almost felt obsessive. Lloyd wondered if he owed some kind of debt to this dragon.

Argh! So hurry up!

Lloyd wondered how on earth he ended up in this situation, playing tag with the Bone Dragon. But he suppressed the emerging misery inside of him. He sparingly shot out mana blasts, ensuring that the dragon's attention was focused only on him. He urgently worked in unison with Ggoming as they flew. Their flight consisted of quick turns and sudden drops to create a distraction.

Lloyd flew in the opposite direction of its flight at times, gliding over its back and passing through its ribs. Enraged, the Bone Dragon wielded its foreleg and scratched its ribs, missing Lloyd by just a hair's breadth. Lloyd then slipped right through its waist. Their altitude lowered with another drop. At the same time, he shook Ggoming's bag.

Pssh! Multiple bundles of spider webs discharged from his bag, sticking to the dragon's face. Lloyd used that chance to widen their distance, flying lower and gliding over the treetops in the garden. His ears picked up the booming noise that ensued behind him. It was the Bone Dragon hurtling their way with even more speed.

Fwoosh! It propelled its whole body at a shattering speed as if it was trying to cover the entire night sky.

"...!"

Lloyd sensed it. He couldn't avoid the dragon this time. The Bone Dragon sensed it too. So, in other words, this was Lloyd's chance.

“Now!“

Lloyd bawled, his voice sounding like a bolt of lightning. Just then, a volcanic-like explosion burst from the woods below.

Boooom!

There was a cave Ppodong had dug in advance, where Bangul was hiding. Her buttock pointed toward the sky from the cave and produced a volcanic explosion. The heat and ash jetted up in a frenzy and covered the area Lloyd just passed by. This blinded the Bone Dragon’s vision for a second.

...!

The Bone Dragon couldn’t see anything ahead of it. Targa, the soul trapped in the Bone Dragon, was flustered. But his panic was short-lived.

This trick doesn’t work against me!

Targa had the power of the Bone Dragon. He could use its raw strength to penetrate the thick smoke.

Boom! The Bone Dragon’s wings tore across the air, moving faster as it generated shockwaves. At that moment, Targa’s sight and consciousness were glued to the back of Lloyd, faintly visible through the thick smoke. So focused and obsessed he was that he didn’t notice it. He didn’t notice that just outside the thick plume of dark smoke that he was passing through, two sword masters were aiming at its weakness with their sharp blades.

Fwish! Javier launched a mana blast beyond the thick layer of smoke.

Fwoosh! The mana blast split through the air and flew at a supersonic speed to hit the Bone Dragon’s 19th tailbone. Bullseye. It penetrated the bone, creating a 20-inch hole in a split second. Cracks formed around the hole. The Bone Dragon’s whole body shook.

“...!”

Targa panicked. Just then, another sword master immediately launched an attack.

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong, in an impressive show of strength, hurled the queen like a ball, and she was catapulted into the air. Her sword was wrapped in a giant aura.

Slash! Her aura sword pierced the 19th tailbone so perfectly. This tailbone had been struck with the mana blast already and was a fake, granite one at the brilliant decision of Lloyd’s cost-cutting scheme. So, it wasn’t able to hold any longer even if it was protected by the body-maintenance magic of the dragon.

Crack! The 19th tailbone explosively splintered into pieces, and right after that, the dragon’s whole tail fell off its body.

Argh!

Targa yelled in dismay. The Bone Dragon, which was hurtling like a wild boar, lost its balance, and it started to flail and fumble in the air like a crab. And thus, an unstoppable descent began.

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Chapter 222: An All-Out War (1)

Argh!!

Targa was baffled. It was an abrupt turn of events. The volcanic ash burst from the ground out of nowhere, and he was simply barreling through the plume of smoke when his 19th tailbone was struck twice and shattered to pieces.

What the...!

Targa was incredulous. He possessed the body of the Bone Dragon, which couldn’t receive damage from the aura swords of sword masters. More accurately, that was what he used to believe.

Dammit!

Targa fluttered his wings in desperation, but it was too late. He lost his entire tail as his 19th tailbone was crushed off. As a result, he completely lost his balance.

Argh...!

In spite of himself, his body lurched forward, and he was getting closer to crashing into the ground with every passing second.

…!

Just like that, he rammed into the ground at the same sonic speed he was flying with. The crash created a 2624-foot furrow, shattering the trees, rocks, and everything surrounding it. He collapsed amidst the storm of dust from his fall. But a little later, Targa, the Bone Dragon, moved.

Boom! Propping up its foreleg on the ground, the Bone Dragon hoisted its body.

Wham! But it collapsed to the ground midway up. The reason was simple. The abrupt loss of its tail ruined the dragon's balance.

We did it!

Queen Magentano exclaimed inwardly and clenched her fists as she saw the dragon from a distance. It worked. Lloyd's plan really worked.

That was close.

The queen recalled her moment of anxiety just a second ago. She and Javier had laid a series of attacks in the smoke Bangul produced with her volcanic explosion. In the last moment, she flung her body to strike the 19th tailbone of the dragon with her aura sword. She almost lost grip of her sword from the repulsive power that fired back at her as she struck the dragon's tailbone.

It must have been because of the mana that sustains the body of the Bone Dragon. Its sturdiness was incomparable to slicing through granite.

It wasn't just an ordinary piece of granite. She felt like she was striking down on a metal slab that was 6.5 feet thick. What would have happened if she hadn't undergone stringent training after her assassination attempt?

I'd have failed.

She would have let her sword go after failing to resist the repulsive power during the most critical moment. And the dragon's tailbone wouldn't have been fully destroyed. However, she did it. The draconian training she went through until this point wasn't all for nothing.

"Whew..."

Queen Magentano fixed her grip as she took a breath, and her gaze flicked over to the thick cloud of dust. Javier was there.

"Then should we go finish the dragon once and for all," asked the queen heavily.

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Javier replied.

This was their chance. It was likely their only chance. The Bone Dragon couldn’t even stand up after losing its tail. But there was no guarantee that it wouldn’t regain its balance soon.

It’ll adapt if we give it time.

There was no way that the Bone Dragon would forever be unable to stand for thousands of years just because it had no tail. In one hour or even less than that, the dragon would adjust just fine. As such, it had to be finished before then.

“Javier Asrahan,” called the queen. “You and Lloyd Frontera can read the flow of mana, I presume?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“I knew it.”

The queen marveled. Raising the corner of her lips, she asked, “Then I shall ask you one thing. What part of the dragon has the most active mana flow?”

“Its skull, Your Majesty.”

“That is what we must destroy.”

That spot would be its greatest weakness. With luck, they would be able to completely bring it down to its knees. The queen and Javier sped their pace toward the crash location of the dragon.

“With all your strength. In one stroke. As soon as possible.”

“I shall keep that in mind, Your Majesty.”

The large shadow of the Bone Dragon, repeatedly rising and falling, came into view through a thick fog of dust. They gradually ventured closer. Without reservation, they sprinted and leaped toward it.

Jump! The queen jumped first, followed by Javier, and landed on its back. The two sword masters sprinted side by side along the Bone Dragon's backbone toward its skull.

Like a while ago.

The queen threw a glance at Javier. He nodded and increased his speed. Then he jumped off the dragon's back, which was violently flailing like a giant ocean wave. He activated the circles around his pulsating heart, clashed them, and let out a blast after transferring the energy from the fierce clash into his sword. *Boom!*

The three strands of consecutive mana blasts flew toward the back of the dragon's skull. To be more exact, they charged toward the part that connects the skull and neck. *Thwack!*

The Bone Dragon flinched along with the explosion. But it was not weak enough to receive any damage. So, Javier prepared more mana blasts. Many, many more. *Thwack! Thwack! Thwaaack!*

...!

Javier fired. He fired once more. Then again in the same spot. He aimed from different angles but was only after one spot.

Bam! Thud! Thump! Boom! Crack! Since one wasn't enough, Javier fired twice. Thrice. Ten times. 20 times. 30 times. All in the same spot. Of course, the Bone Dragon didn't just sit back and accept the attacks.

Ack!

It writhed its body and moved its long neck. It struggled to avoid the mana blasts hitting the same spot, and in the process, it managed to attempt a counterattack by moving its head a few times. But all of its attempts failed. Javier was too small compared to the Bone Dragon. He was nimble and delicate in his movement. No matter how much it struggled by jerking its neck violently, Javier succeeded in avoiding its blows and firing a mana blast in the same place over and over again. But the Bone Dragon was still

unable to stand up on its two feet, so an effective counterattack was nearly impossible. Anyhow, Javier launched a series of unilateral attacks on the dragon. In other words, it was being tortured.

Even Lloyd, who watched the scene in the air, clicked his tongue.

Wow. This is nuts. This is absolutely nuts.

Lloyd admired the sight with his whole heart. He had watched the whole scene from the moment the Bone Dragon crashed into the ground. He meant to wait and see if he should fly away, happy to have wounded the dragon's tail. Or ride the momentum and continue his attacks. But the queen and Javier began to charge first. From then on, Lloyd watched the two sword masters stage a fierce rally against the dragon with slight anxiety. But now seeing the current situation, Lloyd was at ease.

Actually, this makes me pity the Bone Dragon.

That was how tenacious and merciless Javier's attack was. Javier thoroughly practiced the Three Rules of Merciless Beating: Strike the most painful spot, strike the same spot, and strike to no end.

Looks like he'll really defeat the Bone Dragon.

A faint hope appeared in him. The feeling only solidified when he saw the queen bracing for their final blow near Javier who was mercilessly unleashing his attacks.

Is the queen planning on using the giant aura sword she used a while ago?

Its width looked to be over dozens of inches wide and its length well over 13 feet. It was quite literally a giant sword made from a swordmaster's aura.

It was different from an ordinary aura sword.

Normally, an aura sword only had a thin layer of aura covering it like a lightsaber. At best, it would only be about three feet long from the tip of the blade. But the queen's sword was different.

She might be close to becoming a grandmaster.

That thought just popped into his head. Though hers was weaker than the awe-instilling aura Javier created after he became the grandmaster in the novel, it was clear that the queen was getting near that stage.

She must be getting tremendously stronger.

At this rate, Sir Kyle, the previous royal guard commander, wouldn't be able to put up any kind of fight against her. She might even be able to take down two sword masters on her own.

Lloyd then noticed the queen lift her sword. With that, her sword manifested a uniquely large aura sword. Its brute strength contrasted Javier's meticulousness. The aura sword was powerful and massive. It stood over 15 feet tall. It shone menacingly like a weapon made for a siege. On the other hand, the skull of the Bone Dragon was weakened due to Javier's series of mana blasts.

Maybe. Just maybe, she might be able to destroy it.

A faint hope of victory appeared. That was when Lloyd figured he should lend a hand. So, he encouraged Ggoming to fly low and prepared to launch a triple mana blast, determined to fire away should the queen miss her aim. He let Ggoming glide through the air while making his resolve.

The fight beneath him neared in a breath, and Lloyd noticed the queen hurtling toward the dragon, her aura word stretched out. He noticed her zooming off to strike the back of its skull. And then he noticed another scene. He noticed the Bone Dragon strike Javier with its giant tail. *Thwack!*

"...!" Lloyd saw clearly. It was the tail that had been broken off. The tail that was attached below the crushed 19th tailbone snapped off from its body during the crash. It was left on the ground. But it moved. Without any warning. Suddenly and quickly. It whipped around like a giant chain. In a flash, it slammed into Javier.

"Ah...!"

That was the only sound that came out of Lloyd’s mouth. The scene was too unexpected. Watch out! Look out! Move away! He wasn’t able to give them any warnings. All Lloyd could do was gawk at the unbelievable scene of Javier catapulting hundreds of feet away with a booming sound. Soon afterward, Javier fell. Somewhere outside of Lloyd’s field of vision.

“Oh...”

Lloyd couldn’t believe it. What did he just witness? Was that for real? Javier was fighting tooth and nail just a second ago. He was cornering the Bone Dragon by tenaciously shooting out mana blasts. A little more. Just some more. And Lloyd thought they’d be able to defeat the dragon. He was about to help them.

What happened?

Unbelievable. He refused to believe it.

“Javier!”

His shout came a second late. No, he didn’t remember how he came to be shouting. The moment he shouted, he was already encouraging Ggoming to rush and see if Javier was all right. Hurry up, Ggoming, seriously, hurry up. Ggoming hurried at his words. But he couldn’t fly in Javier’s direction. The Bone Dragon was flying now, fluttering its wings and glowering at Lloyd. With its lost tail restored it was blocking Ggoming’s way.

“...”

No way. Does it know my intentions?

Lloyd could feel it with certainty. The dragon was aware that Javier was a threat, and that was why it was blocking his way, lest Javier get treated and well. That would only be trouble for the creature. But still...

“You see, I have to get to him.”

And in a hurry. Javier was slammed in the face with the dragon’s giant tail. It was different from when he was hit by the Gigatitan in Cremo. Javier was

able to skillfully lessen the impact of the blow then. This time, however, he was directly hit and flew hundreds of feet away from the impact. Even if he was strong, that would leave him seriously injured at least. So, he could be in danger of losing his life now. Lloyd had to get to him as soon as possible.

After all, I have the Asrahan Core Technique!

Lloyd could save him as long as he is breathing. He just needed to reverberate Javier's mana circle using the Asrahan Core Technique. That would circulate his mana by force and amplify the natural healing power in his body. This method could bring someone on the brink of death to a less critical state. And bring someone in a moderately critical state to be an averagely ill patient. So, he had to hurry. Now.

"Move!"

Lloyd's bawling came out involuntarily. Was it because Lloyd thought it a great loss to lose Javier? Did he not like the idea of losing his most useful worker and knight? No. Lloyd's heartbeat pounded. To be honest, he was scared.

Javier, you bastard!

Lloyd was scared. He felt a sense of emptiness in a corner of his heart. The scary nervousness ambushed his entire soul. Come to think of it, from the moment he opened his eyes and set foot in this world and met Javier for the first time, he was never away from Javier. What was more, the thought of being forever separated from Javier never crossed his mind. Never. Not even once.

Lloyd never held such a thought. He thought he'd always be with Javier for the rest of his life. Just like now, he thought they'd spend all their time together moving forward. And like they always did, they'd be by each other's side during hard times. Happy moments. Relaxed days. They'd share all these moments as they exchanged insults and corny jokes, growing old as a lazy lord of a fiefdom and his knight. Lloyd always thought so. The thought just came naturally, without much effort from him, much like

breathing. Lloyd believed that Javier would always remain by his side as that was how it had been until now.

But I took him for granted.

Lloyd realized that he had been keeping Javier by his side, enjoying his company and treating him as an equal. And now, he was finally able to recognize why.

Javier.

Lloyd finally saw what Javier was. At last. A guard night? Useful construction equipment? Strong sword master? No, more than anything else, he was...

“Move, you bastard. I have to check on my friend.”

Lloyd’s gaze turned heavy and grim as they stared at the menacing Bone Dragon that blocked his way.

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Chapter 223: An All-Out War (2)

Clank! Lloyd brought out a foldable shovel in the saddle, opened it up, and grabbed it. His heart started to pound.

Can I do it?

Lloyd quickly racked his head. He had to save Javier as soon as possible. The man could be on the brink of death right now. To that end, he couldn't let his emotions rule him.

I must remain rational at times like this.

And calm. Lloyd's gaze cooled down as he pulled himself together. He thought about the situation with great care but also objectively. He formulated a plan in his head. The Bone Dragon was blocking his way, but he needed to get to Javier. After a short deliberation, he quickly came to a decision.

I can do it.

There was no time to waste. He started moving right away.

"Ggoming!" Lloyd called.

"Ggoming!" replied Ggoming as he fluttered his wings. He surged high by pretending to take a left turn. The Bone Dragon fluttered its wings energetically, soaring behind the bird. Meanwhile, Lloyd spoke in Ggoming's ears.

"Ggogming," Lloyd said, "Listen carefully."

"Ggoming?"

"You have an important role right now. You will fly to Javier while I stay here."

"Ggomiming? Ggoming?"

“No, not the other way around. No. I’m staying here. Here.”

“Ggoming?”

“It’s all right. No matter how hard I think, this is our only option. I’ll hold that dragon here. It looks like that dragon is obsessed with me. So, I think I can do a fine job keeping it here. While I do that, you go fly to Javier.”

“Ggomiming?”

“That’s right,” affirmed Lloyd. “To Javier. You saw where he fell, right?”

“Ggoming!” exclaimed Ggoming.

“Good job. Go look for him. He should still be alive. It’s Javier after all. The Knight of Blood and Iron. Once you find him, I want you to take him and-”

“Ggoming?”

“No, don’t bring him here. Go to the city district. Take him to a doctor,” instructed Lloyd.

“Ggomiming?”

“Yes, to a doctor. You heard me right,” stressed Lloyd once again.

“Ggoming...”

“Sure, the best thing would be treating him personally,” Lloyd began to reason in a calm voice. I can use the Asrahan Core Technique to reverberate his circles myself. But I don’t think the situation allows me to do that. That’s why it’s better for a doctor to treat him if I can’t do it myself.”

“Ggoming...”

“That will be enough. It’s Javier. He’ll be able to get better in no time. So, give him first aid and quickly carry him out. Then wait for me near the southern gate of the capital. I’ll run away there.”

“Ggomiming? Ggoming?”

“It’s all right. I don’t have any plans to fight this monster head-on. I’ll buy some time and discretely escape. So, you have nothing to worry about.”

“Ggoming...”

“I’m telling you, it’s fine!” Lloyd assured once again.

Ggoming had become sad without even realizing his feelings. Lloyd put on a smile for him. Actually, he was nervous because he wasn’t sure he could do it. But there was no other option at the moment.

This is the only way to save both Javier and me.

He hated running away alone and wanted to save Javier, his friend. The knight had never left Lloyd’s side after he arrived in this world. So, Lloyd didn’t want to lose him here or give up. That was why.

“Ggoming, I trust you!” yelled Lloyd.

“G-ggoming?!”

Lloyd let go of the saddle at the end of the soar, and his body left Ggoming’s back. Lloyd’s stomach churned with that nausea as he floated in the air just like at the peak of a Viking roller coaster. Then he began to descend.

“G-ggoming!”

The sight of Ggoming shouting in surprise grew distant, and when Lloyd looked down, his vision was filled with the nearing giant of the Bone Dragon. That was only when Lloyd regretted it.

Argh!

As the Bone Dragon filled his sight, Lloyd wondered if this was what ants felt like when they were marching toward a mountain. He had chills coming

down his spine. He was scared and questioned if he had made the wrong decision.

Ugh. Are friends really this important?

He suddenly wished he just abandoned Javier and ran away. However, it was too late for regrets. Lloyd focused his mind. He opened up his arms and legs like a leaping frog, landing on one side of the Bone Dragon's horn on its forehead and clasped his arms around the base of it.

Whack!

"Eek...!"

He almost threw up from the impact. But he succeeded in safely sticking himself onto the Bone Dragon's horn.

Like Ggoming's reaction, the Bone Dragon wouldn't have seen this coming.

He had let go of his grip on the saddle without any warning. That was unexpected for Ggoming, so it must be the same for the Bone Dragon that was chasing after them. What was more, the distance between Ggoming and the Bone Dragon was extremely small at that moment.

Otherwise, the dragon would have happily eaten us in one bite.

Truth be told, he had taken a gamble. Regardless, it worked, and that was all that he cared about.

Arggh!

Lloyd embraced the horn with all of his might and tightly held on. The Bone Dragon was roughly swaying its head to shake Lloyd off after belatedly realizing what had happened. Lloyd felt like a fly stuck to a giraffe that was violently headbanging to a 16-beat rhythm.

I'll go down for now!

He would be doomed if this continued. He would fall to the ground or be scratched to death by the dragon's foreleg. Sensing the danger, Lloyd activated an optional skill right away.

Energizer!

Ding dong.

[The skill option of the Asrahan Core Technique, Energizer, has been activated.]

[The triple circle's efficiency has been maximized. You can move for 20 minutes without experiencing fatigue.]

Ziiing! The circles around his heart reacted right away, the three strands rotated with greater vigor. Similar to the endless circulation of mana that was unique to sword masters, the mana amplified in the circle rotated on and on. From the first, second, third, and back to the first one again. The mana circulated as though it was being recycled, energizing his whole body with everlasting vigor. Lloyd used his strength to bear the centrifugal force the Bone Dragon created by swaying its head. Then he climbed down like a clingy sloth.

Okay!

He continued crawling down, avoiding the occasional foreleg scratches with cockroach-like instincts. He then sent a gaze to Ggoming.

Go! Hurry!

Ggoming was flying circles around him in bewilderment. Lloyd gestured at his bird friend to do what he was told. Ggoming nodded and flew away toward the point Javier fell.

Then it's my turn now.

Lloyd decided to buy time, just enough for Ggoming to find Javier and bring him to safety.

Like this!

Lloyd doggedly crawled down, passed the dragon's crown, and got down with its skull, where there was the socket of its eye.

Excuse me, please!

Without any second of hesitation, Lloyd entered the eye socket, crawling through the passage where the dragon's optic nerves would have sat when it was alive. At last, he arrived at the wide cerebral ventricle. Aggressively grabbing the shovel, he swung down.

Clang! Lloyd struck the inner wall of the ventricle with his shovel, but obviously, he couldn't leave any damage, not even a scratch. But it was more than enough to achieve his goal.

…!

Targa, the warlock in the dragon's body, flinched. A metallic noise clanged in his head. He nearly jumped in surprise from how piercing it was.

Y-You!

Targa was flustered and enraged. He desperately wanted to rip Lloyd to pieces. That archenemy of his not only dangled on his horn but had also entered his skull and started noisily drumming the inside of it!

Get out of there now!

Targa yelled and all his bones trembled. But his shout was only said by his soul, so Lloyd didn't hear it. Thus, it was obviously not enough to stop Lloyd.

"Ha, I like your reaction."

One clanging strike. That was enough to make the Bone Dragon twist its whole body. Its reaction was beyond his expectation. An evil smile appeared on Lloyd's mouth. His shovel started to dance in a more energetic fashion.

“Whew! Ha!”

Clang! Clash! Clang! Clang! Clang Clung! Clash!

S-stop...!

As the shovel became more unreserved in its movement, the Bone Dragon started to writhe and twist with more vigor. At last, it stopped fluttering its wings and landed on the ground. It wrestled to remove Lloyd by shaking and scratching its head. But Lloyd’s optional skill was activated, so he was indefatigable. Instead of getting more tired, his shoveling grew more unforgiving.

“Maybe you like the sound of nails on a chalkboard?”

…!

Screeeech! Screeeech! This time, Lloyd roughly scratched the inside of the skull with his shovel, and the Bone Dragon started to move more frantically. Targa couldn’t be any more annoyed by what was happening. But Lloyd, even though he was harassing the dragon, knew that he had to do more.

More. This isn’t enough. More.

The dragon was only momentarily flustered. It would soon get used to the scratching and beating inside its skull.

I’m not doing any real damage to it.

Lloyd was only acting as a mild annoyance to the dragon. And soon, his fears actualized when the Bone Dragon wielded its foreleg.

Boooom! Unable to bear the metallic noise any longer, the Bone Dragon smacked its head with its foreleg, the force containing thousands of tons of weight. Although the impact wasn’t enough to break its head, it was enough to give a painful blow to Lloyd.

“...!”

The thing was, even if you were riding a solid truck or a hard tank, the person inside could feel the impact of a traffic accident. The harder the object the vehicle hit, the greater the blow would be. Lloyd was experiencing just that.

“Argh!!”

The massive impact shook the whole place inside. And Lloyd’s whole body was thrown to the side, like a person in a car accident without a seat belt, and was rammed into the wall on the other end. Then he collapsed to the floor.

“...!”

He struggled to breathe. He couldn’t scream. Instead, drops of blood spluttered out of his mouth.

“Gargh...! Ha...”

Lloyd wondered if his ribs were broken. No, it felt like all the bones inside of his body were broken. He then attempted to get back to his feet, struggling as he crawled and grabbed the shovel that fell out of his hand from the blow. Just then...

Bam! He heard another blaring noise that seemed to break the sky. This time it came from the other end.

“...!”

Lloyd was hurled away once again. This time hitting the other side of the dragon’s skull. The impact knocked him unconscious, and he woke up only a few seconds later.

C-crap.

Lloyd’s whole body shivered as he grabbed the shovel. No, it wasn’t a shiver. It was a spasm. He knew he had to buy some more time, but he was out of strength. He was struggling to stay awake, let alone stand.

This is how you want to play, huh?

It never occurred to Lloyd that the Bone Dragon would smack its own head. Every body part ached as though his bones were getting crushed. He wanted to run away if he could, but it was too late. There was water under the bridge. A decision was made, and he took action. So, he had to see through the end of it. A bitter smile appeared on Lloyd's mouth.

This is why I hated fighting.

But now that it began, he wanted to win. He wanted more than to achieve his initial goal. Now, he wanted to throw a big punch at this dragon.

Like this!

Ding dong.

The moment Lloyd hardened his resolve as he grabbed his shovel, a message that alerted the activation of an optional skill appeared in front of his eyes.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 2: Latent Power Surge has been activated.]

[Your circle amplification rate has increased fivefold for 30 seconds.]

Ziiing! From then on, his three-stranded circles moved, wriggled, and made an uproar. They rose, roared, and went berserk. That explosive power enabled Lloyd to get to his feet. He didn't give a hang whether he was in a critical condition or not.

I have 24 seconds.

Lloyd had enough time. Today, at this moment, he resolved to attempt everything he could within his power. Then he activated the fourth optional skill of the Asrahan Core Technique.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 4: Circle Shift has been activated.]

Lloyd controlled the number of rotations of the frenzied three-stranded circles and adjusted them to an optimal collision ratio before reverberating them.

Ziiing! Is this what it felt like to put a leash on three roaring beasts? Driven by the Circle Shift, the three sections of the circle fought, entangled, collided, and exploded with each other. At that moment, Lloyd aimed the shovel outside of the dragon's eye socket.

Kaboom! The output was five times more amplified than usual, so that was how much greater the collision was. The triple mana blast's explosive power was strengthened by fivefold. Lloyd carefully shot the blast to make sure he wouldn't be swept away by the force released in the small area. The triple mana blast went out, scratching and widening the dragon's optic nerve passage and leaving its eye socket.

More!

One more time.

Kaboom! The triple mana blast that was amplified by fivefold lightly chiseled the bone around the dragon's eye socket. Though the damage was small, it was enough. After all, Lloyd didn't expect to hurt the dragon with the triple mana blast. It was nothing but preparation for the real deal, his true all-out blow. Just then...

Ding dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 2: Latent Power Surge has ended.]

[As the penalty of the optional skill, you are now exhausted.]

A red message filled his vision. Strength left his body like an ebb. The frenzied circle grew suddenly quiet. But Lloyd wasn't flustered. His eyes instead held more malice.

I told you, didn’t I? I told you to move. I’m going to try everything I can today.

So, he did everything he could. And at last, he activated it—the final move that he had planned to use from the start.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 5: Supercharge has been activated.]

[With this option, you can indiscriminately absorb a large amount of mana from your surroundings.]

From then on, Lloyd fell into a trance-like state. His mana circle opened its eyes again, and they were the eyes of a predator. And everything within his range became prey for him to greedily absorb. And, of course, the Bone Dragon’s skull wasn’t an exemption.

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Chapter 224: New Level (1)

Ziiing! When the Supercharge optional skill was activated at full speed, the three strands of the mana circle rotated quickly, gradually picking up speed and swerving around. The flow of mana rippled like water in a tub, gurgling and swirling down as it was drained. The skill began to absorb all the mana in the air. No, it started to eat it.

Fwoosh! The surrounding air roared with noise, and the dust particles in it thinned out. Even the microorganisms stuck to the dust weren't an exception. The bacteria that swayed around the cilia and the virus that sought the chance to leech in them lost the mana loaded in their molecules and wilted as a result. Of course, the larger targets around Lloyd, like the head of the Bone Dragon, weren't exempted from the blackhole either.

Cruuush! Lloyd was inside the ventricle of the Bone Dragon, and an ominous din rang across the whole space. The dragon's joints clacked as its bones twisted and turned when its mana was usurped away.

Crack! Crush! Crack! The colors of the ventricle changed, and it started to shake as though there was an earthquake. And as if the dragon was writhing in sudden destruction, the whole space that fell within the range of the Supercharge was distorted and abused. This was happening while Lloyd was in a trance, so he didn't notice any change happening. With his eyes closed, he simply plunged everything around him into destruction as he remained still in silence like he was in a cocoon. How did the Bone Dragon react? It simply shook its head as if there was nothing wrong.

What is this?

Warlock Targa murmured in dismay. Lloyd Frontera had been inside his head since earlier, and Targa could sense that the pest was onto something. The nearby mana was being sucked with an intimidating force. That frightened him at first, but just for a second. After that, Targa was unperturbed.

Well, I don't know what he's doing, but he's absorbing mana violently. And quite amazingly.

The Bone Dragon carried far too much mana for him to be scared of what was happening. There was a scary and even stupid amount of mana in its body. So, Targa didn't feel nervous at all, even when Lloyd was absorbing his mana at a fast speed. Unbeknownst to Lloyd, what he was doing right now was the same as bucketing out water in a city-sized lake. That was how much mana the Bone Dragon held.

In short, he's trying to empty a lake with a bucket.

Of course, Lloyd could empty it. But that would require an obscene amount of time. A few years. Or maybe even decades. That was what Lloyd's effort was. A laughable deed from Targa's perspective.

Should I try hitting my head again?

Targa wondered if he should use the same attack he used on Lloyd earlier. But he decided to wait out. With the mana being sucked out of him now, he suspected that his skull was slightly more brittle than usual. It would cause a huge problem if he needlessly launched an attack and created a crack in his skull.

I should wait a little longer.

And just like that, Targa decided to wait.

He won't be able to absorb my mana forever.

That was obvious. Even the most powerful skill was inevitably limited by the threshold of mana the user could take in. Since Targa was once a warlock, he knew this very well. So eventually, the absorption would come to an end soon. He just needed to wait for a bit. That would be enough. Targa's prediction was proven right. Soon, the Supercharge reached its limit.

Ding dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 5: Your Supercharge time is up.]

Ziiing... Inside the Bone Dragon's skull, where Lloyd was sitting now, a message appeared in front of his eyes. The mana circle had calmed now, and the violent rotation slowed, putting an end to the fierce and indiscriminate mana absorption. Lloyd slowly opened his eyes.

"Whew..."

This special sensation that he could feel after using the Supercharge, which he had gotten familiar with, ran through his body as he opened his eyes. He skimmed through the messages that rushed out in front of him.

[The manaheart skill has been upgraded.]

[Skill Name: Manaheart.]

[Stage: Mid-Level Sword Expert Lv. 10]

[Physical Ability Improvement Rate: 1,200%]

[Currently Owned Optional Skills: 1. Shock Neutralizer / 2. Complete Resistance to Poison / 3. Frenzy]

[Required RP to level up: 1,700]

[Your manaheart has experienced exponential growth in a short time by absorbing a large volume of mana of the Bone Dragon. In the process, a small portion of the dragon mana has settled in your manaheart. For this special experience, your skill is awarded new optional skills.]

[Skill Option 4: Half-Human Half-Dragon - By coincidence, a part of your manaheart has come to possess a nature unique to dragonheart. For this, every dragon that meets you will show curiosity instead of hostility. Of course, it is up to you to develop that curiosity into favor.]

Woah. Lloyd was shocked after he finished reading. His manaheart leveled up to own a part of the nature of the dragonheart and make the dragons curious about him as a result. But there was something else that caught his attention.

I'll become a high-level sword expert if I level up my manaheart skill one more time.

Lloyd felt a shaft of panic run all over his body along with anxiety. He was scared that he'd suffer from sword master syndrome once he mistakenly became a high-level sword expert. He'd be an insomniac. But Lloyd brushed the thought away. There was a bigger issue at hand.

What about the Bone Dragon?

What could have happened? Lloyd wondered, thinking that the Supercharge would have knocked out this dragon very well. Lloyd believed that the inside skull would have taken the full blow since the skill ranged over 22 feet.

Then let's head out quickly.

Lloyd quickly jumped to his feet. He knew that the Supercharge wouldn't be enough to end the Bone Dragon in one go no matter how powerful the skill was. But he expected that it would have left a strong blow. A severe migraine. Or a short faint. Anyway, Lloyd figured that he should slip out at this chance.

I didn't expect to defeat the Bone Dragon anyway.

The purpose of this whole thing rested on buying some time for Ggoming to locate Javier and take his badly shaped body to safety. Lloyd's plan served solely that goal.

This is enough.

Lloyd didn't expect anything more. And he didn't want to pick a fight with this monster anymore. So he decided to head out and run away without so

much as a glance behind. Resolving such, he attempted to slip out of the ventricle through a hole when a destructive impact swept over his whole body.

Boooom!

“...!”

Could this be what a beetle inside a soft drink felt like while being thrown against a concrete wall?

“Argh!”

With a crushing noise, Lloyd was thrown to the other end of the wall, his whole body rammed into it. For a moment, he felt his bones dislocated, and he even wondered if his inside had spilled out of him. His vision grew dark for a split second. He couldn’t tell which was up, down, left, or right. He lost all senses.

Gargh...! What the!

Lloyd shook his head in panic, and amid his slowly recovering vision, he continued to think.

Is the Bone Dragon perfectly fine... even after being directly hit with the Supercharge?

Chills ran all over his body. Lloyd wanted to deny it wasn’t the case, but he couldn’t. The very same thing that took place a while ago happened just now. The Bone Dragon had inflicted damage on Lloyd by striking its own head. Nothing had changed from then. So...

The Supercharge skill didn’t do anything to harm it.

Everything became dark around him. It was the blow that blinded him a while ago. But now, it was the overwhelming sense of abyss that clouded his vision. Lloyd, however, gritted his teeth in spite of the looming despair. He started to crawl.

Like I would let myself die in here!

He couldn’t die here. He couldn’t die for someone else, that is, buying time to save Javier. It was too unfair.

I didn’t get to laze around to my heart’s content yet.

His life had been full of toil and hardship. He had lived a miserable, lowly life as the bottom inhabitant of the social pyramid in South Korea, living in an impoverished room rental. It was pretty much the same in this world. A pile of crippling debt pressured him from the start, and he had to work his butt off to clear it. He had overcome several life-or-death crises one too many times.

That’s how I turned my fiefdom into a livable place! And all that awaited me was rest and happiness!

Dying in the hands of the Bone Dragon now? That was too unfair, the strong resentful feeling inside him only strengthened his desire to survive.

No. I’m going to live. I’m going to live no matter what! I’ll live!

With a shovel in one hand and raising his nails, Lloyd crawled with utter desperation. He removed himself from the ventricle, passing through the passages of optic nerves, and finally slipped out of the eye socket. The fresh night air rushed into his chest as he breathed.

“I did it...”

Lloyd beamed. Just then, the Bone Dragon smacked its head once more. *Bam! Bam!*

“...!”

Lloyd snapped open his eyes, and the sheer force helplessly sent him to fly off. If he were a beetle locked inside a thrown can a while ago, now, he felt like an unbuckled driver hurled out of his car as the car collided. Amid the hazy consciousness, Lloyd gawked at the woods speedily passing 500 feet below him as he was flown away into the night sky. A scoff escaped him.

I think I was too... thrifty.

A pang of regret ran through him. RP. CP. He had saved them like a miser.

I should have splurged my RP and become a high-level sword expert.

Had he done so, he might have been able to hold up a little longer than now. He could have avoided this miserable situation where he was thrown to the ground, all helpless and impuissant.

Or CP. I should have used my CP.

Lloyd wished he had used the Ending Spoiler, at least. It'd have then allowed him to brace for this ridiculous final moment of his. He could have predicted today and planned ahead.

I was a fool. I had been too careful.

He felt like a fool for deciding to save the CP because each usage of the Ending Spoiler amplified the points the next time. He had decided to spend it only on occasions he was 100% sure about his bad feelings. Save, and save again. Otherwise, he wouldn't have enough when needed.

I didn't know things would end like this.

His half-hazy gaze moved, and as the gust of cold wind wrapped him, he saw the ground coming close to him at a scary speed. The rocks protruded from the ground here and there, and Lloyd figured that he'd be jellied once he landed there. That, Lloyd told himself, was the spot he'd die. Shivers ran down his spine. He opened his eyes wide, trying hard to be cool about the incoming death. But right before he was nailed to the ground, someone grabbed his belt.

Clack!"Lloyd Frontera! Wake up!"It was the booming voice of the queen. Lloyd felt a massive grip force along with the shout. He answered his savior's calling violently.

"Argh!!!"

Lloyd dry-heaved as the momentum of the fall was broken by the grip, which gave a sudden tightening to his stomach. He felt like he was going to be split in half.

“Wergh! Achew! Arrrgh!”

Lloyd felt a severe pang of pain even though he was only half-conscious. The pain was so great that he couldn’t faint. But thankfully, it allowed him some sense to look around.

“Get on my back, now!”

The Queen?

In no time, he realized that the queen was carrying him on her back and starting to sprint off toward the garden. She jumped over the shrubs and broke the sculptures that stood in her way with her sword. She broke through, breaking everything. A violent race and scattered breathing. Heat transferred to Lloyd from her back, and he even felt her desperation. She was running away with him on her back, away from the Bone Dragon pursuing them. A snort escaped Lloyd just then.

“Your... Majesty.” Each word spilled heavily out of Lloyd’s mouth. “Why... are you saving me?”

“Why, my foot!” The queen bawled. “I am saving you because you will die if I leave you alone! Is it your wish for me to abandon you and run away?”

“Please do not do that...” Lloyd answered with sincerity.

He couldn’t utter words like, “Your safety comes first, Your Majesty. Leave me and run away.” He wouldn’t dare say those. He was afraid that the queen might agree with his meaningless words and leave him saying, “Yes, it hurts me, but you are right.”

I don’t want to die.

Lloyd struggled and lifted his head. Carried on the back of the racing queen, he looked behind. The moon was nowhere to be found. Instead, he saw a

giant figure ready to sweep his way. It was the Bone Dragon hot on their heels.

“...”

The queen was slow, Lloyd noticed. At this rate, they would get caught.

“Your Majesty,” called Lloyd.

“What?!” She snapped.

“I entreat you to run faster.”

“I am doing that already!”

“Take my mana, Your Majesty.”

“...!”

Her back flinched for a second when Lloyd placed his hand on her shoulder and squeezed the last bit of mana in him to transfer it to her.

Ding dong.

[You are now exhausted. Therefore, you are under the influence of the Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option 3: Power Saving Mode. Your mana amplification rate is fixed at 25%, and the whole amount of mana you can transfer to someone is limited to 2.5%.]

Ziiing!

It was a mere 2.5%. But that was enough. Even a bit of strength was better than nothing. That would still slightly increase their chances of living.

“By now, the royal forces must be ready to attack,” Lloyd pointed out.

“I know!” retorted Queen Magentano.

“To that way... You should run toward the forces.”

“I am doing that!”

Lloyd encouraged the queen, and she started to race more hurriedly. He wondered why the reality was so harsh in moments like this. Why was that Bone Dragon flying to catch up on them without ever getting tired?

Baaang!

“...!”

A blaring noise roared, and the dust storm blew. Lloyd sensed that the queen stopped in her tracks fast.

“Oh...”

He then heard her collect her raspy breath and mumble. Lloyd lifted up his head too, and there was the Bone Dragon standing in their way like a wall of despair. His gaze met the dragon bending over.

“Ha, haha...”

Laughter escaped him. It was over for real now. He had done everything in his power. Nothing more came to his mind, even when he beat his brain. At that realization, Lloyd burst into fits of laughter. And as he felt her shoulder tensing in fear, as he stared at the giant silhouette of the Bone Dragon coming in his way, Lloyd sensed his last moment. And he forced the corners of his lips to rise amid the terrifying shivers. And he thought to himself...

Javier. I’m going to die here. But you should live, you rascal.

Lloyd inwardly begged Javier to survive with the time he had bought for the latter. Take good care of Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, Bibeong, and Ggoming. And the good Count, Countess, and Julian. Feeling a little bit unfair about this whole thing, Lloyd added that Javier should have a fat belly, balding hair, and athlete’s foot because it would be too unfair if this boy gets to live so well without him.

So...

Lloyd looked up. The Bone Dragon had its mouth wide open now. It was rushing in his way, closing as it neared to eat them up. Its pillar-like fang was fulgurated. Just then, a sword ray shining brighter than the fang appeared in a flash and blocked it.

...!

He didn't make any sounds. There wasn't even time to feel anything. Right when something seemed to have glimmered, Lloyd opened his eyes wide.

Javier?

Out of nowhere, Lloyd saw the back of the silver-haired knight. Javier was standing in front of Lloyd, blocking the latter's way as though Javier was protecting him and fighting against the enemy. And when his long sword let out a force that split into thousands of iridescent auras, something popped into Lloyd's head. The novel. The image in the story. The final level Javier reached. That was...

"Grandmaster?"

The moment Lloyd mumbled, the Bone Dragon was sliced into thousands of pieces.

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Chapter 225: New Level (2)

Splash! Ten minutes ago. Submerged in the swirling river, Javier was dying. Opening his eyes proved to be a struggle, but when he did, it was all blurry. Nothing could be made out properly. Even the touch on his skin felt strange. Something felt cold, wet, and bubbling.

River water.

Javier thought to himself. Finally, he was somewhat conscious. He figured that he was under the Magena River after being thrown out hundreds of yards away from the fighting scene.

The tail... moved.

The tail had been definitely sliced from its body. Javier was certain that he got the dragon for good when it was immobilized. He was certain that he could defeat it by smashing its skull.

But I let my guard down too much.

He was an idiot for that. His mistake was being convicted of a victory that was yet to be his. It never occurred to him that the snapped tail would move on its own to sweep him away. But Javier soon stopped, believing that he was only giving out excuses. It was time to face reality.

I must go back.

He grew urgent. There was no time to think in here. He had to return and stop the dragon. But... his whole body had lost strength. He couldn’t even lift a finger.

“Cough!”

Brrr! He coughed with great struggle, and the remaining air in his chest bubbled out of his throat. Resultantly, his body plunged further down into the lower portion of the river. Deep down to the very bottom.

“...”

He couldn’t breathe. And as the consciousness he painstakingly clutched onto started to fade, he repeated the names that kept popping up in his mind.

My Lord... And Young Master Lloyd.

Javier vowed to protect them in the face of tribulation and even death. He promised himself to keep them from harm until his last breath. But it looked like he wouldn’t be able to fulfill that promise.

Please forgive me.

Against his will, a scoff escaped him. The vow was grand, but he was not. He was doomed to miserably drown at the bottom of the river. How pathetic, he berated himself. He hated dying this way and leaving Lloyd alone in danger. That is, he wanted to protect his young master. Was it because he was the son of the lord and successor of the fiefdom?

No.

That wasn’t it. It used to be in the past. But now, Javier had somewhat realized that there was another reason. But it wasn’t anything grand. He didn’t want to see Lloyd die or get hurt. He wanted Lloyd to laze around and grow old, much like the wish that the latter expressed from time to time. He wanted to remain as a knight by Lloyd’s side until his wish was achieved. That was it.

So...

He urged his body, begging his system to move. He tensed up his whole body in utter desperation, yelling at his broken arms, legs, and body to move as it was time to get out of this water and go back to fight. He urged, scolded, hurried, and cornered himself. But later, his heart stopped beating.

No...

That was it. His consciousness was cut, and his whole body became limp. The bottom of the river was cold and dark. With his eyes open, sank to the bottom, his body followed the slow current of the water, and just like that, he met his death. As his heart stopped beating, his blood stopped flowing. The flow of blood in the carotid artery to his brain came to a halt. Once his oxygen was cut off, his brain cells screamed, and every cell in his body struggled. His nerves, fasciae, muscles, and marrows begged for oxygen as they insisted they could move some more. This couldn't be the end. They resisted defiantly in the face of the inevitable death. Every fiber in his system begged to keep his body alive. It was a miserable last-ditch effort. A pathetic act of begging. And now that his oxygen supply was cut off, they started to absorb other resources outside of oxygen. Fortunately, there was a good resource. Mana.

Ziiing... Even when his body was dying away, Javier's heart held a large volume of mana. It was the manaheart of a sword master, and the three-strands circle that wrapped it. The traces of voluminous mana circulation remained in his body like a historical record of his past. Then his history recalled his memory. The traces rekindled the circulation and mana thumped in his body.

Ziiing... The circle gradually started to move again. Each organ in the body yearned for mana, and the circle instinctively moved to satisfy the desperate demands. It provided mana to every corner of the body, filling up the depleted blood vessels and stimulating the struggling body.

Ziiing! The circle's rotation stepped up its speed. It squeezed out every mana left in the manaheart to avoid the incoming death. It then amplified and poured out everything it held to all of Javier's body. With that, the manaheart was emptied. And yet, the circle continued to spin, squeezing out more without holding anything back. It continued until even the manaheart itself was gone.

Ziiing! The circle's violent rotation went beyond its limit and melted the manaheart, Javier's manaheart beginning to fade away like cotton candy in the spring and spilled ink, like a sweeping storm. It melted and smeared into all his cells, equipping each with a manaheart. Before this moment, the manaheart was only a large lump sitting in his heart. But now, it was

different. He had 60 trillion somatic cells and 60 trillion manahearts. Multiply both, and that was the amount of its resonance. All of the processes formed a network along the blood vessels, its distance reaching over 62,137 miles. It dispersed, disseminated, and amplified without holding anything back. Finally, everything amounted to one big explosion.

"...!"

He was silent. Javier had no time to be aware of anything. He didn't know how his eyes had opened, how he had gotten out of the river. How he'd gotten here. It was a mystery even to him.

Soon, Javier made sense of things. He woke up to find himself out of the river and back on the battlefield. Before he knew it, he had his back against Lloyd and Queen Magentano, with the Bone Dragon hurtling toward them. Gazing up at the dragon, he could see it.

I can feel it plainly.

The blowing wind. The difference in air density. The mana pool loaded in it. The borders of the minute mana whispered. The way his sword should be wielded was engraved in his heart. The place he wanted to focus his strength came into his view. So, he did. He raised his sword and wielded it sideways. So casually. Nothing special. He just wielded his sword the way his heart told him to. And when he opened all of his manahearts, the somatic cells in his whole body reacted. The manaheart as many as the somatic cells burned, creating a resonance that reached infinity. It was then amplified into the three-stranded circle. And just like that, he sliced a portion of the world.

...!

Likewise, there was no sound. The sword ray glinted in the split second he blinked. That was enough.

Slice. Lines formed across the body of the Bone Dragon. One, two, three, five, ten, 100, and 1,962. The 1,962 strands of aura rushed into the air. No,

it broke through it with a sharp noise. The body of the Bone Dragon met the same fate.

…!

The Bone Dragon was shattered into thousands of pieces and defenselessly scattered in various directions. *Thud! Twang! Boom!*

It was like the whole area was struck with a salvo of dice-sized bone pieces. But Javier gave no mind to the dragon anymore. After he put the sword into his ordinary sheath, he turned and checked on the people he had saved.

“Your Majesty, are you well?” asked Javier.

“Y-Yes... As you can see...” murmured Queen Magentano with a dazed look on her face. She couldn’t believe what spectacle she had just witnessed.

What was that just now?

It was beyond her comprehension. The shocking sight was too much for her to understand in mere seconds. But soon, she realized that there was something more important than that.

“Oh, more than that, here.” She spoke as she put down Lloyd she was carrying. And she took a step back.

“Master Lloyd,” called Javier as he approached Lloyd. “Are you awake?”

“Yeah...” Lloyd’s voice was raspy.

“Are you okay, Young Master?”

“Do... I... look okay in your eyes...?” A faint smile appeared on Lloyd’s face.

He was far from okay. Really. Every part of his body was sore and in pain. He felt like he had at least broken a few bones. It looked like he also suffered a concussion. He kept dry-heaving, which was torturing him to no end. It was so severe that he wanted to commend himself for achieving the

miracle of not passing out. Even though it was painful, Lloyd was able to put on a smile nonetheless.

This rascal is really something.

The sight of Javier brought a smile to his face. Javier didn't die. He was safe. Completely fine. And that spectacle of taking down the Bone Dragon?

He has done it. He's now a grandmaster.

Lloyd could sense it. Javier's aura was split into thousands of strands when it slashed through the entire space. The Bone Dragon was chopped like pieces of radish in a second. That spectacle was rather familiar in Lloyd's eyes as he had read the novel. That part never failed to overwhelm him, even after reading the same passage many, many times. Thankfully, Lloyd was able to ease his mind.

It's a relief.

Actually, Lloyd had been worrying that Javier's growth was stagnant. He was afraid that by completing the Asrahan Core Technique and teaching Javier about the mana blast, he had taken away his chance for self-growth. Part of him was bothered that his teaching poisoned Javier's growth. But today, he was relieved of that burden right away.

And we've overcome this crisis.

Feeling relieved, Lloyd let out a breath of ease. Meanwhile, Javier placed his hands on Lloyd's shoulders.

Ziiing... Lloyd felt his powerful mana streaming into his body from the shoulders. He even felt Javier kindly spinning the mana circle for him. A comforting mana slowly traveled throughout his body.

Ugh...

He wondered if this was what it felt like to rest after a day of work on a luxury massage chair but not before hitting the sauna and a bowl of warm

soup. Lloyd almost moaned but stopped just in time. And soon enough, the emergency treatment was over.

“Whew...”

Lloyd snapped his eyes open. Now feeling light, he sat up. There wasn’t any pain anymore. The parts that he had thought were either broken or fractured had been completely healed. Lloyd turned to face Javier, who treated him.

“Hey, you,” called Lloyd.

“Yes, sir.”

“You’re not expecting me to thank you for what you did, are you?” Lloyd lifted his chin.

“Of course not.”

“Really?” asked Lloyd again, narrowing his eyes.

“Yes,” Javier assured. “You are not that kind of person, after all.”

“You know me well. You were about to tell me that I am a petty, vengeful person and whatnot, weren’t you?”

“You know me well,” said Javier with a smile.

“Yes. I know you very well. I know what you have accomplished too,” hinted Lloyd.

“Did you... figure it out already?” Javier’s voice contained mild disbelief.

“How can I not?” Lloyd scolded and pointed with his chin at the thousands of shattered pieces of the Bone Dragon that lay on the ground. “You just did that with one stroke of your sword. So, how can I not? It was the Bone Dragon, for Pete’s sake.”

“...”

“Anyway, congratulations.”

“Thank you.”

“Thank you?” huffed Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Are you thanking me because you know what I’m congratulating you for?”

“Well, of course, it is because I have become a grand-”

“Grand what?” put in Lloyd.

Javier stopped and said nothing afterward.

“I don’t give a hoot about your grand… whatever that is,” huffed Lloyd. “But hey, I just saw how smoothly you chopped everything into pieces.”

“Excuse me?” Javier retorted.

“You chopped it to pieces. That.” Lloyd chuckled and pointed to the Bone Dragon’s skeleton. “The pieces are all uniform in size with a sleek surface. Very nice. Nice indeed. Now, you’re going to make a fine granite cutter. It’ll be easy to cut them up into thousands of pieces of blocks and tiles, right?”

“...”

“This is what you call ‘mass production’,” Lloyd said proudly. “Standardization. Regularization of size. And flawless quality guarantee. So you just have to slice things like that from now on. I’ll do the selling. The profit will be a ratio of nine to one. Of course, I’m going to have 90 percent of the profit, while you take the ten. Got it?”

“...”

“You’re going to be rich too, man.” Lloyd congratulated.

“Ha...”

Finally, Javier could not repress his laughter anymore. Lloyd was smiling as he tapped his shoulders with force. This young master was making a corny joke right now, and Javier could see from his eyes that Master Lloyd was rejoicing. Not only because he had reached a new level in swordsmanship but also because he was safe. Javier felt pure joy in Lloyd. And the feeling was mutual for Javier.

I am glad that you are safe, Master Lloyd.

There was no need to speak it out loud. Just a silly joke was enough. Javier’s desire to protect Lloyd, and Lloyd’s heart to cherish and worry about Javier. The two understood each other without needing any words, and that was enough. It was enough, even if they outwardly hurled insults at each other.

“Is that so? Then congratulations, too,” said Javier.

“Congratulations? For what?”

“Since you are alive, you can always be made fun of by me whenever you want.”

“Ha,” said Lloyd defiantly. “Are you seriously going to make fun of me for being 30? Do you really think that will have any effect on me?”

“No.” Javier shook his head.

“Then what?”

“30-year-old...”

“Stop it,” Lloyd broke in.

“...virgin.” Javier ignored it and finished it.

“I said, don’t say it.”

Just like that, Lloyd chuckled like a fool and got up with the support of Javier. That was only when things became real to him.

I'm alive.

Javier was helping Lloyd get to his feet, and the Bone Dragon's remains were sprawled all across the area. The unbelievable event started to feel real now. He finally took in that he had gone through a life-or-death experience. That was when he was able to relax a little bit. Just then, unexpected messages appeared in front of him.

Ding dong.

[Your Zombie Domination skill has spotted a new entity that can be dominated.]

[Object: Bone Dragon]

[Status: Critical Condition]

[The Bone Dragon, which is originally strong, is unexpectedly in a critical condition. Therefore, the mana in it is almost depleted. Due to this, the condition to dominate with your basic domination skill has been satisfied temporarily. Moreover, once you succeed in dominating, the object will never be freed without your permission.]

[Would you like to dominate the Bone Dragon?]

[YES / NO]

"..."

Lloyd exclaimed "Jackpot" in his head after reading the messages, and his eyes widened.

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Chapter 226: What Goes On Inside the Dragon (1)

Dang. I hit the jackpot.

Lloyd's eyes widened. He carefully read the messages that appeared in front of him with an incredulous heart.

The Bone Dragon is dying? It's almost out of HP and suffering from terrible exhaustion as it's depleted of mana. And so, this is saying the condition for my Zombie Domination is satisfied for now.

Lloyd decided to take his chance, so he quickly opened the skill window and floated the details of the Zombie Domination skill in front of his eyes.

Ding dong.

[Skill Name: Zombie Domination]

[Stage: Basic Lv.1]

[You can dominate a set scale of undead soldiers. The undead soldiers under your domination will provide unconditional allegiance and faithfulness to you.]

[Types of undead soldiers you can dominate: zombies and skeletons.]

[The number of undead soldiers you can dominate: 200]

[The current number of undead soldiers under your domination: 200]

[Required RP to level up: 50]

[Current RP: 2,632]

Hmm, the skill details that only the zombies and skeletons can be dominated. But how is it that I can dominate the Bone Dragon now? Wait, does that mean...

Lloyd postulated that it could be because the Bone Dragon was in a critical state, quite literally with its low HP. So, it was close to something like a zombie or skeleton for the time being. That was how he satisfied the Zombie Domination condition. If that was the case, there was no time to lose.

Whatever the reason is, it means that my skill will work. I'd be a fool to miss this chance.

Money on the floor was meant to be taken. A free-tasting sample was to be tasted. Coupons were to be collected. Perhaps, it was a little cheap and pathetic. But that was how Suho Kim survived in South Korea. Lloyd moved right away and activated the Zombie Domination skill, throwing his gaze at the remnants of the Bone Dragon cut up into thousands of pieces. But...

Ding dong.

[Zombie Domination has failed.]

[Error Code: 00A1, Capacity Limit]

[There is no space to accept another undead entity. Either fire an entity you are currently dominating or expand your span of domination.]

Dang. What a novice mistake.

Lloyd scolded himself for being too impatient. Hurriedly, Lloyd opened the skill window.

The sweet reward in front of me was so great, I lost my cool for a second. I can't act like this. Pull yourself together, Lloyd.

He invested his RP, and the result came out right away.

[Skill Level Up!]

[Skill Name: Zombie Domination]

[Stage: Basic Lv. 2]

[Types of undead soldiers you can dominate: zombies and skeletons.]

[The number of undead soldiers you can dominate: 210]

[The current number of undead soldiers under your domination: 200]

[Required RP to level up: 70]

[Current RP: 2,582]

Perfect.

Now, he had enough capacity. Lloyd's gaze moved restlessly toward the Bone Dragon, his eyes containing conviction and greed. He activated the Zombie Domination skill right away, and the reaction came immediately.

Ding dong.

[Zombie Domination skill has been activated.]

[The designated entity, the remains of the Bone Dragon, started to react to the skill.]

[1,963 pieces of its skeleton have been recruited minus one.]

[Among the 1,963 pieces, one piece is resisting the skill.]

Hmm?

Lloyd lifted his brow when he learned that over 1,900 pieces of the Dragon Bone were recruited except for one, and it was under protest.

What is this now?

Lloyd was afraid that his skill would be disabled while he wasted time like this. The mana of the Bone Dragon could recover its health level above that of zombies and skeletons.

Then I won’t meet the condition.

Lloyd’s neck broke out in a cold sweat as the chance to turn the Bone Dragon into his minion seemed to fade away. If that happened, it’d be the same as cooking a delicious pot of soup, only to spill all of it before serving by slipping.

That won’t do.

Lloyd’s eyes hurried. Just in time, a new message popped up.

[Would you like to see the details for the protesting piece?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it’s a yes!

[Loading the details...]

Ding dong.

With a refreshing ding, a wall of information cascaded in front of him, and Lloyd quickly moved his eyes like a person going through the monthly account history of their credit card.

[The piece of the bone that is currently protesting against the Zombie Domination is identified as a parietal bone.]

[As the result of the scanning, a soul leeching in the bone has been detected.]

[The leeching soul is resisting the Zombie Domination.]

[To view the information on the soul, please select “Here.”]

Lloyd selected it without hesitation. And the information on the soul that was protesting to Lloyd’s skill and leeching in the Bone Dragon’s parietal bone was revealed.

Ding dong.

[Leeching Soul]

[Name: Targa]

[Gender: Male]

[Age: 47]

[Occupation: Warlock]

[Height: 5’8]

[Weight: 134 lbs]

[Other information: Low blood pressure, neurotic indigestion, balding hair, salt tooth, sauce pourer, unmarried, forever single, ambitious, leader of the warlock organization, and killed in the hands of Queen Magentano while planning a host of treasonous schemes.]

“...”

Aha, Lloyd exclaimed inwardly. The leader of the warlocks was here. The information on the soul that floated in front of his eyes gave him an insight at last.

This case was like the Trojan Horse.

Lloyd recalled how the queen had suppressed and defeated the warlocks, who perished without even having a second to respond. The suppression was said to be much easier than everyone had expected, and it ended with the queen slicing the head of the leader. But the queen must have missed something in the process.

This warlock must have transferred his soul into the Dragon Bone right before he died.

Just like the Trojan Horse. Just like how the Achaean army hid its elite soldiers in the Trojan's Horse for the ambush, the warlock must have hidden his own soul in the Bone Dragon.

And that was why he was obsessed with me.

Lloyd recalled how the Bone Dragon ran riot and laser-focused on him for some strange reason. He had no idea back then. But now, once the identity of the soul was enlightened, Lloyd understood.

He must've thought I put a brake on his plans in Namaran. Tsk. This is the problem with the villains. They blame others when the fault lies in them.

Lloyd moved his eyes, this time more relaxed. And he continued to read down the messages.

Ding dong.

[The soul living in the parietal bone has been identified.]

[You can eliminate the identified soul at your will.]

[Would you like to eliminate?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a yes.

There was no reason for hesitation. Lloyd nodded right away. Just then, he heard a faint shout coming from the parietal bone.

"H-hold on!"

Hmm?

The voice seemed to belong to a sly, insufferable old man. Lloyd figured it was Targa. His voice continued shouting in a more hurried tone.

"Hold on! Don't do this! Listen to me!"

“Hello? What did you just say?”

“Yes! Give me a chance!”

“A chance?”

Lloyd snorted as he shrugged his shoulders. And he gave Targa, who was begging in desperation, a belittling laugh.

“Why are you asking me to give you a chance?”

“What...?”

“Ask who’ll judge you, not me.”

“H-hold on!”

Clack. Lloyd selected “YES” without any hesitation. And then came the shouting of Targa, whose scream sounded like a flushing toilet. Unsurprisingly, he was soon met with a joyful message.

[The soul of Warlock Targa living in the parietal bone of the Bone Dragon has been eliminated.]

[Now, all of the 1,963 broken bones of the Bone Dragon are reacting to your Zombie Domination.]

[The Zombie Domination skill has succeeded.]

[The Bone Dragon is now yours.]

Yes! This is what I’m talking about!

It was a success. Lloyd clenched his fists because he now held control over the Bone Dragon. But there was one more process left before actualizing it, and that was the restoration. Thankfully, Lloyd didn’t have to put a lot of effort into it.

[The Bone Dragon attempts to restore its body in accordance with its “Immortal” nature.]

[Its mana inside is gradually being restored.]

[The broken bones are piecing together.]

Crack... Crack... The shattered mass of the Bone Dragon, which was the masterful work of Javier, began to tumble on the ground. It started to absorb the surrounding mana, like the Asrahan Core Technique. And just like that, the Bone Dragon restored itself on its own, putting together all of its broken parts and returning to its original shape. Meanwhile, Lloyd struggled to stop Javier as the latter grabbed his sword again when the bones jerked.

“Wait! Stop!” yelled Lloyd in a rush. “That’s mine now.”

“That... is yours now, Master Lloyd?” asked Javier, his voice breaking in disbelief.

“Uh-huh.”

Javier looked at the dragon and back at Lloyd, his sword pulled out of the sheath just midway. There was curiosity and dismay in his gaze.

“You may have not heard him,” Lloyd hurriedly threw an explanation to convince Javier. “The Bone Dragon just spoke to my heart.”

“What did it tell you? What?”

“The baby of the Skeleton Corps. That is, it wants to enter as the newest member.”

“...”

“You beat it to a pulp,” coolly explained Lloyd, “so it surrendered.”

“Is that true?”

“Sure is. Look.”

Lloyd lifted his one hand, making a thumbs-up gesture and looking at the Bone Dragon. The Bone Dragon in the middle of the restoration reacted and made the same gesture.

“Did you see that?” said Lloyd.

“...”

“I’ll elaborate on the details later on. First, we have to restore it to one piece. Got it?”

“Yes... I see...”

Javier was at a loss for words. The Bone Dragon had been wreaking havoc on everything just a moment ago, and he had ripped the creature into shreds. So, Javier wasn’t easily persuaded when Lloyd said that he recruited the dragon and got it to enlist in the Skeleton Corps. It felt unreal even though he was looking right at it.

But it’s evidently a fact.

Javier could feel it by alternately looking at Lloyd and the Bone Dragon. In just a matter of seconds, its whole body became intact as its broken bones and dislocated joints started to come together. The Bone Dragon was now bowing obediently at Lloyd. What could be his secret? Javier mused. There was no way of knowing. Curiosity, reverence, and confusion appeared in his eyes as he looked at Lloyd. While he was thinking over these things, Lloyd was focusing on the restoration.

Okay, the restoration is going well.

Lest the assembling goes wrong with a missing bone part, Lloyd carefully observed the process as though he was choosing the best pork cut to treat himself or observing the pack of potatoes he selected after much deliberation or selecting the biggest bread in the rack. Lloyd’s eyes shone sharply.

[The Bone Dragon’s body has been restored.]

[The regenerated Bone Dragon now owns a new personality.]

[Its new personality is like a blank page.]

[From now on, the words that you tell will have a significant influence on its new personality.]

Messages cascaded in front of his eyes. Lloyd realized right away that this moment marked the final process and the most crucial moment in having the Bone Dragon under him. Catching on it, Lloyd quickly put on his thinking cap and beat his brain for the things to say. And then, he spoke.

I am Lloyd Frontera, your absolute owner and the most respectable and reliable creature in this world. Moreover, you are a proud member of the Skeleton Corps I manage. You are an excavator that says, "How deep?" when I say, "Dig." You are a crane and so much more. A construction machine is perfect in all ways. So, you enjoy labor all the time. Chores make you happy. And safety comes first. Hurray, big hurray for Master Lloyd. If you get what I'm saying, shoot me a finger heart.

Lloyd sent those strong thoughts to the Bone Dragon as he looked at it. The Bone Dragon reacted immediately.

Rumble...! It lifted its body and spread out its wings. And then, it raised its foreleg in the most polite manner and made a finger heart. At the same time, a refreshing message appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes.

Ding dong.

[Your Zombie Domination on the Bone Dragon succeeded.]

[From now on, the Bone Dragon will become a faithful worker and dutifully perform all of your commands.]

[The list of your Zombie Domination has been updated.]

[The number of undead soldiers you can dominate: 210]

[The current number of undead soldiers under your domination: 201 (↑1)]

Nice. Super nice!

It was done. The dragon was even officially registered. Thus, the giant Bone Dragon was his minion. After confirming the fact, an acute desire to dance swelled over him. But just then, another unexpected message appeared in front of him.

Ding dong.

[Manaheart Skill Option 4: Half-Human Half-Dragon has been activated.]

[The dragon soul nearby started to show interest in you.]

Eh?

Lloyd wondered what was happening.

A dragon soul is interested in me?

Confusion flashed across his face. The next moment, a voice of the soul recognizable only to Lloyd came from the Bone Dragon, who still was making the “I love you” with its fingers.

“I am the dragon from ancient times... I am Anticus... The original owner of this skeleton... Which is now yours... If you do me a favor... I will report to the Dragon King of your good deed... Please... Help... Me...”

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Chapter 227: What Goes On Inside the Dragon (2)

“Please... help me...”

Hmm?

Lloyd blinked hard as he heard something strange. It sounded like a vague scream coming from hundreds of yards away. So, he wondered if he had heard it wrong. But that wasn’t the case.

The message appeared just a while ago, I think? It wrote that the option has been activated.

The option pertained to the optional skill, Half-human Half-dragon, added to his manaheart skill, which Lloyd had acquired after using the Supercharge skill inside the dragon head. The option had a simple effect. It would cause dragons to become curious about Lloyd.

It’s not a bad option.

Most dragons were hostile to humans. Like how people grapple their slippers or newspapers at the sight of a cockroach, dragons first thought about ending humans when they saw one. But with this option, Lloyd was spared getting killed without initially being inquired by the dragons. It made him an object of curiosity at first glance. Now, a message appeared stating that this skill had been activated. Lloyd focused on his hearing. Soon, the voice from a moment ago began to sound clearer.

“There... Can you hear me...? I am Anticus... An ancient dragon... I ask for help from the one listening to my voice...”

It’s real.

Lloyd did hear something. The voice continued to speak.

“I am Anticus... An ancient dragon... A member of the great tribe that once conquered the world... I ask help from the one who laid his hands on my

bone...

It was clear. Lloyd could postulate to whom this voice belongs.

Could it be that this was the Bone Dragon's voice when it was alive?

It looked like so. Lloyd thought for a second.

Oh, sh... I kind of want to pretend I didn't hear it.

Should I just ignore it and pretend I didn't hear it? Such desire surged from his heart. It looked like helping the dragon out would result in a lot of bothersome work for him.

I don't know what it wants, but I don't want to get involved. I already have a lot on my plate now.

Lloyd gazed around. The Termina Garden. The very garden that used to be splendorous and marvelous. But now, it was likened to a room that housed 30 young children on Christmas night. In short, it was a mess.

I have a feeling that the restoration construction will be a fairly lucrative job.

And the money from the undertaking could be amassed in the storage back in the Frontera fiefdom to be used as his retirement fund. The mere thought of it overwhelmed his heart with a sense of reward. And so, Lloyd made up his mind to ignore the voice and was about to force-shut the Half-Human Half-Dragon option when...

"Oh, you who are listening to my voice... I sincerely request this for your sake... If you do not lend me your helping hand... My noble bones will break down into powder in three years..."

"I am here. I believe you need my help?"

Lloyd reacted at the speed of light, his eyes glimmering. The queen and Javier shot a strange glance at Lloyd, who was talking to himself from their perspectives. But Lloyd couldn't care less about them.

Obviously. The bone is going to turn into powder in three years? The Bone Dragon will be gone? I can't let that happen!

Lloyd hated doing favors when there wasn't any benefit for him. But when the expiration date for the Bone Dragon was going to be three years after all that he had to go through, he had to help out and prevent that from happening. And so, Lloyd replied to the dragon voice, whose voice dripped with joy when it came back.

"Ha... A kind... human, I suppose. Are you not one of the warlocks that abused my bone...?"

"Not at all," assured Lloyd.

"Is that so?"

"Yes. I'm not. On the contrary, I defeated them. Do you know a warlock named Targa?" asked Lloyd.

"I... am aware of the name. He excavated my body... And abused it."

Lloyd sensed violence in its voice. And so, he jumped in and replied, "That villain. I took care of him."

"You did?"

"Yes," assured Lloyd. "Just a short while ago. Wasn't he living in your parietal bone?"

"Seeing as you know that... I believe you are not lying..."

"Yes, that is what I mean."

Since it was the age of self-PR, Lloyd earnestly appealed his accomplishments to the dragon voice. Thankfully, the voice warmed up a little. And evidence of the change soon appeared in front of him.

Fwoosh! The finger heart gesture of the Bone Dragon began to glow, and light gradually floated from the fingertip. The light then created a video in

the air.

A film letter?

Lloyd sensed that it was, and he was right. A dragon skinned in green appeared in the video. The horn had the perfectly same shape, and judging from the state of the skin and countless scars, Lloyd postulated that the Bone Dragon was old. The image seemed to show the dragon when it was alive.

“What now...”

Queen Magentano’s eyes widened at the emergence of a dragon video floating high in the air. Hardly minding her, Lloyd focused on the video. The dragon in it opened its mouth and spoke, its voice loud enough for everyone to hear.

“This is the record left by Anticus, the ancient dragon, a fragmented letter kept in a glass tossed in the sea. Moreover, it is a gift and favors for the human who will help me.”

The dragon in the video, Anticus, rolled its ember eyes. And it lowered its body with dignity like a living dragon.

“First, I wish to know the name of one who responded to my voice.”

“I am Lloyd Frontera.”

Lloyd replied fast lest someone spoke for him. Anticus smiled with satisfaction.

“Good. Human Lloyd Frontera. Thank you first for responding to my voice. Are you ready to help me?”

“Um, I first wish to hear your conditions,” said Lloyd.

“Condition?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded before asking back to indicate his confusion as to why it was asking the obvious. “I cannot lend you my helping hand without listening to what it is about, right?”

It was truly what was right and the most obvious. That was what Lloyd thought.

That really is the case. The most troubling question in the world is this: Hey, can you help me? But the person never tells you what their request is about. They just ask for your help and demand an answer before anything else. What the heck, seriously?

Lloyd believed that the proper thing to do when you ask someone for help was to tell them what help you need. Lloyd hated getting tricked into a scheme and suffering from any losses or liabilities.

Even if the Bone Dragon expires in three years, I’d feel this way still.

Lloyd seriously wanted the Bone Dragon to be part of his Skeleton Corps. His heart thumped in immense anticipation at the thought of putting the monster to work. But what if maintaining the dragon’s form required a significant amount of effort from him? What if it came with an unexpectedly great cost? If so, he’d abandon the dragon without hesitation. Lloyd thought it was an obvious choice.

I mean, what other choice is there? How’s that different from buying a high-end car with a loan when you don’t have the money to maintain it?

So, first thing first. Lloyd had to have a clear understanding of what that dragon wanted. Lloyd stared up at Anticus with such desire in his eyes. It appeared that Anticus took the hint.

“Ha.”

A scoff played across its face.

“Yes. You’re right. Technically speaking, I’m the one begging for help. Fine. I shall do what you say. I will elaborate on my request.”

“Yes, I am all yours,” answered Lloyd, his voice happy.

“To cut short, my soul has fallen into the depths of hell.”

“Hell?” uttered Lloyd in mild surprise.

“Indeed.”

“Then how do you explain yourself in this video?”

“This video is really me, but it is not my soul. It is just a letter I drafted right before I was dragged to Hell. A magical letter I threw in the sea that is the world, using my bone as a glass bottle.”

“...”

Hmm. So, the video was just a video letter but with a considerable level of magical artificial intelligence. That was why it was able to mutually interact with another intellectual entity. That was what it seemed, concluded Lloyd.

“Well, anyway, what kind of help do you need when you’re in Hell? It can’t be something like dragging you out of it, right?” Lloyd surmised.

“That is it.”

“What...?” Lloyd said in shock.

“Your guess is right. The warlock and his men that you defeated a while ago used my body for all sorts of evil purposes. My soul was resting when it was cursed and got dragged into Hell. So, I ask you. Please, go to Hell and save my soul.”

“Okay, goodbye.”

Lloyd bowed as soon as he heard Anticus. And he was about to instruct the Bone Dragon to shut this video. He would have done it had Anticus not yelled.

“Wait! You cannot turn down my request, can you?”

“I am.” Lloyd shrugged and turned Anticus’s way. “I’m not foolish enough to go to Hell!”

“But-”

“Absolute bogus,” defied Lloyd. “You see, I have a bright future ahead of me. I have no reason to set my foot on Hell yet, so why should I ride the Hell-bound express train to save you, a complete stranger?”

Lloyd was being frank. Going to Hell and saving a soul? Lloyd wondered if this dragon had lost it the moment he heard its words.

“I mean, it’s not like I’m a hero in a legend or myth or a son of a god. How dare you try to send a perfectly ordinary person to Hell? What are you, a siren? Aren’t you trying to drag me down with you to not suffer alone?” Lloyd huffed in almighty annoyance.

“That is not it!”

“Then I’m sorry, but why don’t you consider it your fate and stay there? I don’t want to go to a place like Hell. What’s more, I don’t know the way there either.”

“I can open up the gate to Hell right now.”

“No, please, I said there’s no need.”

Lloyd was flabbergasted. He had just shot a quick response because he heard that the Bone Dragon would become powder in three years if he didn’t assist it. It never occurred to Lloyd that this Anticus would have such an absurd request. He felt the same as when he opened his door for mail, only to be met by religious people trying to share their beliefs.

Hell-bound?

It was nonsense. He would refuse even if he was given ten dragon skeletons.

If that's the condition, then I'm not going to keep the Bone Dragon. It kind of sucks, but I'll live perfectly fine even without it.

Losing the Bone Dragon would be much more beneficial than being thrown into Hell. Safety came first, more than anything else. That was what Lloyd thought. Just then, Anticus rushed forward and started to speak.

"Wait! If you save my soul, I will provide massive, unimaginable rewards!"

"Excuse me?"

Unimaginable compensation? Massive rewards? Lloyd's ears jerked instinctively the moment he listened.

Shoot. I shouldn't listen to it.

Lloyd deliberated for a second. He then decided to hear it out first. So, he looked up without saying anything. Anticus spluttered in nervousness.

"Did I not say it a while ago? This video is the greatest gift and favor bestowed upon the human who will help me."

"So, what is this great reward?"

"Official support from Dragon King Verkis."

"Excuse me?"

Verkis? The official support from the Dragon King? While Lloyd was thinking about it, Anticus continued to speak.

"If you help me and lead me out toward the path of rest by saving my soul from the pit of Hell, I, Anticus, shall report your good deed to the Dragon King and the bravery filled with goodwill."

"So, you're going to set me up so this Dragon King can fund me?" asked Lloyd.

"Indeed."

“What good is there?” asked Lloyd once again. Here came the important part. Assistance was good, but it had to be specific. He needed to check thoroughly what benefits he’d be getting.

It’s obvious. We go over the benefits of our plans when we sign a contract with a carrier for our phones. Even in supermarkets, people negotiate the accrual rate of their shopping points when they sign up for a membership card. This time, it’s over the Dragon King’s support. So, I should do some math and nitpick what gains I’ll be making in specific terms.

It couldn’t be any more obvious. Lloyd stared at Anticus with a gaze of a picky customer.

“What good is there for you?” Anticus replied in dismay.

“Yes.”

“Hmm, first of all, you will never lack money for your entire life. The dragon cave the Dragon King lives in is filled with more treasures than this world has.”

“Oh, oh,” exclaimed Lloyd in joy. “I like it. And?”

“You will have two lives.”

“Wait, I will be able to resurrect?”

“That is it. The magic of the Dragon King is said to be profound that even the dead can be brought back to life once.”

“And?”

“Those are the main benefits.”

“That’s it?” Lloyd asked to see if there were anything more.

“Who knows? Additional benefits may come depending on how much the Dragon King likes you. But I can promise you one thing.”

“What is it?”

“I can promise you the surest way to safely exit Hell when you help me out and go there.”

“The surest exit?”

“Yes. Just once. I can mark your hand with one disposable magic that can open up the exit gate of Hell anytime, anywhere you want.”

Anticus then stopped talking after listing the benefits of receiving the support of the Dragon King and the way to get out of Hell. Lloyd nibbled his underlip.

Hmm...

He was on the fence.

The Dragon King’s offerings are more appealing than I expected.

It was beyond his expectation. It wasn’t just about gaining a powerful supporter. A bottomless pool of treasure. The ability to resurrect. And if lucky, there were set to be more. Moreover, the Bone Dragon wouldn’t have an expiration date for its usefulness.

Goodness, this is bad. I’m intrigued.

The money and the Bone Dragon weren’t exactly what appealed to him. It was the chance for resurrection. This world was just too harsh for him to live a carefree life. And so, having a chance to resurrect once would bring more stability to his relaxed, happy, and carefree life.

But the condition is going to Hell. Whew.

That part bugged him. But at the same time, there was the minimal safety device, a chance to leave Hell at any time once. The benefits the dragon suggested were too appealing.

Hmm... With these benefits, I don’t think it’s entirely undoable.

Lloyd then threw a glance to the side. Javier was watching the conversation between him and the dragon without saying anything. Javier met the gaze. And he looked at Lloyd suspiciously as if he understood the meaning of Lloyd's glance. Lloyd grinned without a word.

Yes, let's just say that you've become a grandmaster for this purpose.

When Lloyd looked at Javier, he started to be more hopeful. The rough journey to Hell looked somewhat bearable, at least a little, with the grandmaster by his side. They could likely overcome most of the small obstacles that came their way. Lloyd decided to drag Javier down on this, and, at last, he reached a decision.

"Good," Lloyd said, "With a generous heart, I shall help you, Dragon Anticus. But..."

Lloyd's hand moved to point at Javier, who was looking at them with curiosity. And he shamelessly added, "That friend over there must go with me!"

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Chapter 228: Along with Money: Hell (1)

“Let me take him with me.”

Whoosh. The wind blew. Lloyd’s fingertip pointed to Javier. The corners of Javier’s ears flinched. To Hell? Together?

I meant to obey his command if Master Lloyd made such a decision.

The image of the dragon that had suddenly appeared. Lloyd who had negotiated with the image. As he listened in to the conversation, Javier believed that he would be with his young master should the latter choose to help the soul of that dragon and descend to Hell. Javier had inwardly resolved so to himself. But now...

I resent him.

Javier decided to drop the matter. It felt like the roots of his soul were thrown into chaos. In a half-defeated way, Javier nodded. A wide grin hung on Lloyd’s mouth.

Whew.

Javier’s eyes narrowed as they moved toward Lloyd. However, Lloyd didn’t care. Lloyd simply gave a big smile to Javier, and his brazen smile seemed to say, “So, you’re not going? You’re going to send me alone? Wow. Javier. I thought better of you.”

“...”

Javier decided to drop the matter. It felt like the roots of his soul were thrown into chaos. In a half-defeated way, Javier nodded. A wide grin hung on Lloyd’s mouth.

“Yes, it looks like this friend agreed. I and this friend will go to Hell to help you. But!” Lloyd paused before continuing for effect. “I want you to vouch for the rewards you promised in return for our assistance.”

“Vouch?” Anticus cocked its head.

“Yes, vouch.” A meaningful smile hung on both sides of his lips. “There’s a vouch between parties even when they’re loaning small amounts of money. We’re helping you out in Hell out of all places by throwing ourselves in harm’s way. Don’t you think we need some kind of guarantee of a reward?”

“But I promised.”

“A verbal promise hardly means much.”

“Are you saying we should draw up a contract then?”

“No, I don’t think it’s going to have any effect on this.”

Lloyd shook his head. It was true. There wasn’t any effectiveness in signing a contract with the video letter the dragon left before it fell to Hell. The soul of that dragon lost nothing by violating the terms in it. Therefore, it had to offer something, a giant loss, if it didn’t fulfill its promises. That was the only promise and guarantee Lloyd could trust.

Thinking such, Lloyd said, “Swear on your soul.” *What...?”* You’re making a promise anyway, so I want a guarantee of it with the vow of the soul,” suggested Lloyd.

“What are you saying...?”

A look of dismay appeared in the image of Anticus, and the corners of Lloyd’s lips rolled up as he looked at it.

I knew it.

The vow of the soul. He commended himself for bringing it up.

That vow has more weight than a verbal promise.

It was a vow that could only be made once in a dragon’s lifetime on the utmost important matter. And humans didn’t know anything about it. It was exclusive to dragons.

And if one party breaks it, its soul is destroyed. Forever. There's no way to bring it back. Its existence disappears from this world for eternity.

To be more explicit, it'd be like erasing a character in an RPG game.

"Human. How do you know about the vow of the soul?"

Its eyes were now serious. But Lloyd decided to act brazen. How else? I read the novel, Lloyd said to himself.

"But that's not what's important now, is it?" reminded Lloyd.

"That's-"

"Vow or no vow? Answer me."

"..."

"Without that much certainty, I won't budge," Lloyd said, setting his foot down.

Lloyd was being genuine here. There was a lot to gain by making a slave out of the Bone Dragon. The endless treasures and an extra life. But despite such tremendous benefits of being a member of the Dragon King club, it entailed traveling down to Hell. Sure, there was a safety device, an exit from Hell, but it didn't offset all risks. So, he adamantly told himself that he'd not move an inch unless he was given a vouch that was proportional to the risks.

"Whew," sighed Anticus. *"Do you really want that vow?"*

"Of course."

"Goodness. I never imagined making this vow after my death and to a human at that…"

"Then you can leave it," huffed Lloyd.

"H-hold on!"

“Anything you want to say?” Lloyd said as he lifted his chin.

“Of course I do. I did not say that I would not make that vow.”

“Are you scolding me for being impatient?” frowned Lloyd.

“That is not what I am doing.”

“Then, what is it?”

Lloyd stared at Anticus with the attitude that said, “Take it or leave it since I’ve got nothing to lose.” Eventually, Anticus raised the white flag.

“I will do it.”

“Do you really mean it?” asked Lloyd.

“Since I said that I would do it, the vow has been executed.”

“Awesome.”

Lloyd was happy. It was just like the novel. The vow of the soul took place the moment one uttered the intention to do it. There was no strange chanting, flashing a magic circle, or any other dramatic procedures involved. A vow was literally a vow. A promise was literally a promise. It happened the moment one said it would be done. That was it. And it was actually the scary part as well. The simple words, “I’ll do it,” held the weight of one’s soul as failure to fulfill the promise meant the eradication of their soul. Nonetheless, thanks to that, Lloyd was able to place his full trust in the vow Anticus had just made. Now, the latter’s gaze held warmth toward Lloyd.

“Thank you… for helping me.”

“Please do not mention it. Just make sure to fulfill your vow.”

“Of course. Once my soul is saved with your help, Dragon King Verkis will be your supporter. Now, then, I will open the path of Hell.”

Bzzt! As soon as Anticus was done, sparks buzzed in the air, and a circle portal that was about six and a half feet in diameter appeared in the air. Lloyd saw a glimpse of the scary scene inside with plumes of smoke bursting out of volcanoes. His skin stung from the hot and stuffy air blowing onto him.

“Here, the gate to Hell is open. The other side is Hell.”

“...”

“It is quite hot in there, so be careful. Make sure to be mindful of Satans that roam around Hell. They take joy in deceiving good souls and perverting them.”

“Then,” asked Lloyd, “where is your soul in this place?”

“I do not know.”

“...”

“But I suppose the King of Hell has his hands on my soul.”

“Whew.”

After hearing that much, Lloyd breathed in. Was this really happening? Who would have ever thought that he’d be meeting the King of Hell? Even though the gate to Hell opened right in front of him, Lloyd was still in a daze. But the decision was already made, and Anticus made a vow. And so, success in this job meant...

I will obtain the support of Dragon King Verkis.

The Bone Dragon. Everlasting treasure. Two lives. Add to that...

“Lloyd Frontera. In the end, do you plan on leaving my side like this?”

Lloyd turned and looked at the queen. She had been listening to the conversation with Anticus by his side. And so, she had become somewhat

aware of his intentions to accept the dragon's wish. The queen let out a chuckle, and Lloyd bowed courteously to pay his respect.

"Certainly not, Your Majesty."

"Then?"

"Even having the support of the Dragon King, I will never leave your side," assured Lloyd.

"Do you mean you will remain as my subject until the end?"

"Yes, Your Majesty."

"And yet, you are wary of doing the things I ask." There was a slight aghast in her voice.

"That is-"

"I am already aware." The queen's bitter smile deepened. "I have experienced and seen today. And yet, why do you presume that I am ignorant?"

"..."

"Sir Asrahan at your side has completely ascended above the levels of a sword master at last. Although I have no way to ascertain that the feat he performed a moment ago was the level of a grandmaster, it is plain that no troops of mine can easily defeat him," stated Queen Magentano.

"Your Majesty."

"And now, you have the Bone Dragon at your command, correct?"

"That is true, Your Majesty."

"Your knight who rose above the level of a sword master. Your obedient subject, the Bone Dragon. These two alone already signify that the powers of your house have surpassed the throne," stated the queen.

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“It is time that you do not have to ask for forgiveness.”

“Certainly not, Your Majesty. I wish to ask for your forgiveness on and on.” Lloyd insisted before hanging his head down and revealing, “I have told you this before, Your Majesty. I only wish to lead an ordinary and peaceful life in my fiefdom.”

“I am aware.”

“Yes, Your Majesty. As such...” Lloyd paused before speaking. “Dominions and powers do not interest me. All I wish is to relax in peace, so I still need Your Majesty’s support.”

Those words came from his heart. And sure, the queen was right that Javier, the grandmaster, and the Bone Dragon could overpower the House of Magentano. Seriously, he could wage war against any country on the continent. But Lloyd didn’t want to do that.

Why would I do that?

He could live happily without doing so. A happy, laughter-filled life awaited him at the fiefdom, where he was spoiled in many ways. He was free from worrying about being short on cash, rent or transportation fees, or unpaid wages. He was eternally liberated from such a life of agony.

And what? Dominion war? King? There’s no reason for any of that.

Lloyd didn’t want it, either. If he tried, he was certain he’d find himself under a terrorizing amount of work. It guaranteed he’d never be able to live lazing around like a rich landlord.

That won’t do.

So, Lloyd decided to keep things modest. He had to remain a favorable subject of the queen. He would enjoy life under her reliable rule.

To do that, I need her cooperation.

After organizing his thoughts quickly, he looked down. With precise calculations and an honest heart, Lloyd spoke to the queen.

“Therefore, Your Majesty, I shall not reveal Sir Asrahan’s new level and the existence of the Bone Dragon to the outside world. I only ask that Your Majesty treat me as an indolent subject.”

“An indolent subject?” asked the queen for clarification.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“So nominally,” she presumed, “you will be my subject. But you shall refuse all the work I give you.”

“Certainly not, Your Majesty.”

“Then?”

“There is the support and assistance I received from Your Majesty until now. I am a man who not only remembers my enemies but also my saviors.”

“Really?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Really?” she stressed once again.

“Yes, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd with equal emphasis in his voice.

“Hmm. We will see,” said the queen.

“...”

“Anyway, you mean that you have room to interpret my assignment as a favor, that is, depending on what the job is. Your favor. Did I understand it correctly?”

“Truly yes, Your Majesty,” answered Lloyd.

“Tsk. You are a smart and impertinent man, but the problem is that I do not hate you.”

Queen Magentano clicked her tongue. She couldn’t help it as she could clearly see through Lloyd’s intentions. His desire was to be a slacker and live a relaxing life despite the massive power he possessed. He was asking for her cooperation to make that a reality.

Well. I should be relieved about it.

She pictured a fictional scenario for a second. What if, really if, Lloyd and his family decided to raise a coup? Would she and the royal family be able to suppress them?

No.

She swiftly drew a conclusion. It was impossible. The Bone Dragon alone required the mobilization of all the forces in the palace. Add to the Bone Dragon, there was Javier, the grandmaster. Her leadership would be destroyed. Her control system would fall apart. The number of remaining troops would mean nothing without any leadership, and they’d eventually scatter away. Thus, that would lead to the fall of the royal troops and the Magentano house.

“...”

Though she only imagined it for a moment, the mere thought made her hair rise. And so, the queen smiled at Lloyd Frontera, who was paying his respect to her. She appreciated him for making the suggestion to remain as her subject.

“All right. I shall grant your request.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

The queen nodded. Lloyd bowed to the ground. A content smile appeared on his lips.

The labor exemption. I finally got it.

His shoulders shivered as he was overcome with emotion. He'd have hula-danced and shouted in joy if no one was here.

As expected of the queen. I had faith in her.

A monarch with a generous and bold heart. A just and principled figure. Lloyd had trusted those qualities of hers. And it was from that faith that he was able to make such a request, and he was spot on.

It's a relief. If the queen was a small-hearted person, then none of this would have worked.

A typical monarch wouldn't be able to sleep at night so well in the knowledge of the subject outpowering the royalty. They might chuckle that everything's fine, but behind their backs, they'd rack their brains to assassinate the subject or find ways to neutralize them. But Queen Magentano wasn't like most monarchs.

She isn't. She'll instead use this opportunity to strengthen her power.

Of course, she would concern herself to develop a deterrence that would prevent Lloyd from getting too ahead. But the deal here was simple. Both Lloyd and the queen had to continue their life without clashing against each other. They would accept each other and co-exist. And to press on this choice to the queen, Lloyd intentionally accepted and joined the Dragon King club in front of her, declaring that he'd be joining hands with a power greater than herself. And now, against that backdrop, he suggested that she never bother him as he wouldn't go berserk but instead respect the queen and live in peace in return. The queen saw his intentions right away and chose to support him. Satisfied with the deal, Lloyd rose and looked at the gate of Hell.

"Whew."

The volcanic ash and lava ground appeared in vague shapes through the thick smoke inside the gate. The sight slightly made him feel more aware of his situation. It was time to go to Hell to become a member of the Dragon King club and be awarded endless treasures, the Bone Dragon's unlimited

labor, a live-once-more ticket, and enjoy other benefits. At the same time, all the demons in Hell detected the gaze Lloyd was throwing into the gate. They lifted their heads and grabbed their thumping chests. And they recalled the very title Lloyd was known for all at once in unison.

What?! Sir Frontera, the devilish singer, is making his way here?!

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Chapter 229: Along with Money: Hell (2)

Fwoosh! They were in an unknown place inside Hell. Floating in the air, the Hell gate was spinning like an angry beast while spluttering out fire. Suddenly, something else was spluttered out. It was Lloyd and Javier.

“Oops...!”

Lloyd closely managed to recover balance and land safely without crashing down. But he soon winced and withdrew his foot.

“Ouch! It’s hot!”

Sear! The rocks on the ground were soft and half-melted from the heat. Lloyd’s shoes were slightly scorched on the bottom.

Wow.

Coming to terms that he had entered the fiery pits of hell, Lloyd surveyed his surroundings. Just then, the events he had experienced right before his arrival to Hell struck his mind.

***

“Is this it, Lloyd Frontera?” asked the queen. “Do you plan to go to Hell now?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” affirmed Lloyd.

“How heartless of you. I was hoping you would leave after helping me clean up this mess.”

“I will leave Bibeong behind, Your Majesty,” he said.

“Is that so?” asked the queen.

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd then hung his head down without hesitation, which prompted the queen to make a wry smile. There was slight

wistfulness in her expression.

She shrugged before adding, “Well. It was the dragon that asked for your help, so it is only sensible that you want to take care of it first. Thankfully, there weren’t many critically injured people or deaths considering the size of the incident.”

It really was the case. Given that the Bone Dragon had torn this place apart, the damage wasn’t substantial. Apart from the royal magician killed by the dragon early on and some royal guards, there was almost no casualty.

“It is all thanks to you,” the queen said.

“That’s-”

“No,” she broke in before Lloyd could finish. “No need to deny my words. It is all thanks to you who shocked the visitors into fleeing by bringing out a giant beaver.”

“...”

“If you hadn’t taken action, countless of them would have wound up in the tragedy and got killed. I truly appreciate you for setting an example and for your valiance,” said the queen.

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“Tsk. You and your empty words.”

“...”

“Every time you say these things, my hatred toward you soars through the roof and I wish to send you to Hell. However, through a method different from the one you are about to take.”

“...”

Lloyd smiled awkwardly, hoping to himself that the queen would talk without the sword in her hand. To be honest, Lloyd, too, knew where she

was coming from. Lloyd was a reliable, trustworthy, and astute subject who lived without any greedy ambitions. It wasn't easy to come across such a great underling. No, the mere discovery of such a talent was a miracle. And so, she would never want to lose him. That was why the queen felt wistful. She was wistful as Lloyd had grown too strong for her to order him around like before. That was why she was making these sharp jokes.

Haha, but it's kind of ridiculous how I'm calling myself a great talent.

Lloyd thought so because, in the first place, he was just an ordinary guy who had slightly more knowledge of this world than other people here. His astuteness and ability to read the room? Those were helpful only because he was slightly more knowledgeable about the circumstances and future of this world, which he had gotten from reading The Knight of Blood and Iron. And so, Lloyd never overestimated himself. Instead, he resolved to keep a low profile.

I can't become cocky and act recklessly just because things are going a bit smooth for me. That behavior led many people to fall to their demise throughout history.

The same went for him, who now had the Bone Dragon and Javier, a grandmaster, under him. Even though he was on the crest of a wave and held massive power, he could potentially get brutally assassinated against his luck. Such was life. There wasn't any guarantee that it wouldn't happen. And so, Lloyd told himself long before that he must never antagonize the queen. And his mind hadn't changed.

"Your Majesty, I can only come back to your side if I go to Hell through the method of my choice." Lloyd's voice was cool and convincing.

"Is that so...?"

"Yes, Your Majesty," answered Lloyd.

"But you see," reasoned the queen, "even if I behead you, I have a feeling that you will come back to life after tricking the demons in Hell."

“I am overly flattered, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd, lowering his head.

“Are you?” asked the queen, arching her brow.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Your sly behavior keeps making me want to test your words,” she growled playfully.

“...”

“Do not worry,” she said, her voice softening. “I am pulling your leg.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

“If you really do, make sure to come back safely to my side again.”

“I will try my utmost best, Your Majesty.”

Yes, Lloyd wanted to come back. That he was sure about. He didn’t want to stay any longer than he had to in a place like Hell. After their conversation, Lloyd lent his helping hand to the cleanup by bringing Bibeong to the site, who was limping in the wake of the 3,000-ton body-press attack. There was some convincing and coaxing in the process of leaving him to the queen. And then, Lloyd took Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, and Ggoming in his inner pocket. As for the Bone Dragon, he ordered it to be on standby.

“Quietly hide yourself somewhere nearby.”

Creak? The Bone Dragon cocked its giant head like a large, meek puppy trying to make out its owner’s words. A smile erupted from Lloyd’s mouth.

“The people here won’t react well if they see you. They’ll be terrified. You don’t want that to happen, do you?” asked Lloyd nicely.

Clack! Clack! The Bone Dragon nodded its head earnestly.

Lloyd said, “That is why I want you to hide near the capital until I return from Hell. Away from people’s sight. Better if you submerge yourself in the

sea without the presence of any humans.”

Clack!

“It’s all right,” cooed Lloyd, “You’re not going to die. You don’t even breathe, do you?”

Clack!

“If monsters like the Gigatitan try to harass you, just flick them with your foreleg. You’re stronger,” assured Lloyd.

Clack!

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded. “I’ll be back quickly. I promise.”

For some reason, Lloyd got the feeling that the Bone Dragon he acquired from the Zombie Domination skill had a new personality of a giant puppy. Finally relieved by the promise, the Bone Dragon flew up in the direction of the sea north of the capital. As for Lloyd, he roughly cleaned up the mess from the incident and left the rest to the queen.

“I’ll leave now.” With that, he stepped toward the Hell gate and crossed to Hell with Javier.

“Whew...”

He had been lost in his reverie just for a while, and yet, his nose was already prickling.

The whole place reeks of rotten eggs.

There was a pungent, rotten stench that pricked their nostrils. It was the smell of sulfur. Their view was equally unpleasant with volcanos everywhere within Lloyd’s sight. Lava spilled out along the large and small mountain ranges like a milk carton bursting from the side. Grass? Shrubs? Green trees? They did not exist here. The whole sky was gray with smoke. Could it be the reason why?

“Ehem. Ah-choo! Cough!”

It was Javier, who kept coughing beside Lloyd. It seemed that he wasn’t used to the smoky, polluted air. However, Lloyd was completely fine.

Well, this is similar to the air in Seoul.

To be specific, the air was as murky as the streets in Hongdae, Seoul on the days with the highest levels of fine particulate matter.

I went around without a mask then, too, because I had no money for them.

Lloyd had no way of avoiding exposure to air pollution even if it was harmful to his body. Some days were better than others when Lloyd managed to pick up some anti-dust masks from construction sites. But on days he failed to get them, he had to bear the terrible air and bank on having a healthy respiratory system. Thankfully and ironically, his vigorous respiratory training back in South Korea made his alveoli shine and reveal their worth in Hell.

“Tsk. This is enough to make you cough?” Lloyd smirked pitifully at Javier.

“Ehem...!” Javier waved his hands. “That is not! Ah-choo!”

“My, my. I thought you said you’re a grandmaster.”

“...”

“And yet, you can’t handle this?”

“Ah-choo...!”

“Tsk. You’re like a weak indoor plant that’s only ever breathed fresh air.”

“...”

Lloyd smirked. Even if one was a grandmaster, it would take time to adjust to breathing polluted air. He broke out in laughter at the discovery of his single point of superiority over Javier. But that wasn’t his only good news.

Ding Dong!

There was a sudden noise of alert, and unexpected messages cascaded in front of Lloyd's eyes.

[Your title <Top Gun from the West> has been put into effect.]

[You are now in a region with an average annual temperature of 104 degrees Fahrenheit. "Top Gun from the West" has been activated. You will never get dehydrated under any circumstances during your stay here.]

Yay.

Satisfaction danced in Lloyd's eyes when he read his messages.

That explains why I haven't felt overly warm since a while ago.

When he first arrived in Hell earlier, he didn't think it was particularly hot given the volcanoes and magma surrounding him. He didn't sweat much, either. It all turned out to be thanks to his title.

I made the right choice to build the Qanat for the sultan in the desert. Wow. Never did I expect to use my title like this.

Lloyd had no idea that he'd be coming down to Hell back then. He never even imagined he'd come to a monstrous neighborhood that was 104 Fahrenheit year-round. He merely thought he obtained yet another title and moved on. To him, it just meant he'd be safer in desert areas. But now that he was in Hell, there wasn't a better title he could have.

"Hey, are you hot?" asked Lloyd.

"I am fine, ah-choo, ehem!"

"But you're sweating buckets."

"It's bearable," assured Javier.

“Tsk. You’re a weakling.”

“...”

“Seriously, knights these days just don’t have any mental fortitude. Not an ounce of it.” Lloyd shook his head regretfully.

“...”

Lloyd looked inside his inner pocket. “Everyone all right?” he asked.

“Ppo! Bang! Ha! Ggo!” Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, and Ggoming nodded happily inside his pocket.

“How is the temperature?”

“Ppo! Bang! Ha! Ggo!”

“It’s all right? But Ppodong and Ggoming look a little hot.”

“Ppo! Ggo!”

Like Lloyd observed, Ppodong and Ggoming seemed to be having a tough time as they were covered with fur, unlike Bangul and Hamang whose body was sleek and hairless.

“Then why don’t you guys step outside instead? And Ggoming?”

“Ggoming!” exclaimed Ggoming.

“You take this.”

“Ggomiming!”

He fed a red sunflower seed to him, and he hopped on Ggoming’s back with Javier. As for Ppodong, who was panting from the heat, he got on Lloyd’s shoulder.

“Now, we fly!” ordered Lloyd.

“Ggoming!” exclaimed Ggoming.

Soaring across the sky in Hell, Lloyd was able to look down on the surrounding area. It thankfully allowed him to see the spot he could fly toward.

That must be it.

Beyond the horizon, there stood a strangely shaped volcano. It wasn’t anything like an ordinary mountain. To analogize, it looked like a demonic churro. And that churro-looking mountain was bubbling with lava. At the sight, he suddenly recalled reading a descriptive passage about Hell from the novel.

The novel said that the Castle of Hell, where the King of Hell lives, had an outline of a person writhing in agony. And at the top, the King ruled over every soul that fell in here.

The mountain in the distance perfectly fit that description. And so, there was only one conclusion he could make.

That is the place.

That was where the King of Hell resided. And so, the soul of the ancient dragon Anticus had to be entrapped there.

“Ggoming!” called Lloyd. “Let’s fly there, how about it?”

“Ggomiming! Ming!”

Now that their destination was set, he didn’t have to go on an unnecessary adventure and travel by foot. Thinking so, Lloyd encouraged Ggoming to fly, and the unfamiliar view of Hell sped by beneath them. One hour. Two hours. Three hours. Five hours. And nine hours passed by.

We’ve flown this much, and why does it feel like we’re not getting close?

Lloyd clutched the back of his neck in distress after spending almost half a day flying. They weren’t getting closer to the twisted mountain where the

King of Hell was at. No matter how many times Ggoming fluttered his wings, even when Lloyd was sure they were flying toward the mountain and when the ground beneath him sped by, for some strange reason, the mountain was getting closer. Not at all.

This is nuts.

There had to be a reason. A reason why he couldn't get close to the mountain. But Lloyd had no clue. Nothing changed even after he rummaged through the novel's content in his head. He couldn't recall any mention of a phenomenon like this one. Just when he was feeling a bit hopeless, he spotted something.

Hmm?

Lloyd, who was gazing around in dismay, spotted something within his vision. And he called Javier behind him and said, "Hey, Javier. Your vision is better than mine, right?"

"Yes, probably," answered Javier casually.

"Then do you see that?" Lloyd pointed to an area on the ground.

Knitting his brows, Javier focused his gaze there. "I see it. It looks like a human."

"Right? And am I correctly seeing that the person's skin is a little off?"

"Yes, you are correct. Their skin is bright red like the color of blood. And their head... has a horn on it."

"A horn?" Lloyd cocked his head as if he hadn't caught that.

Javier replied, "I am sure of it. There is a horn jutting out of them."

"Then that means-"

"It is a demon, a demon living in Hell," Javier finished.

“You’re absolutely right. Bingo. What perfect timing. I just needed to ask for some directions,” said Lloyd.

“Wait, do you plan on approaching the demon?” Javier frowned.

“Of course. I have a grandmaster with me, so why should I be afraid of that demon?”

After giving a nonchalant response, Lloyd told Ggoming to fly down toward the demon in their distant view. Like a driver asking a passerby for directions after circling around in a strange place, so naturally, Lloyd got Ggoming to land near a demon.

“Hey!”

The demon flinched in surprise at the sudden landing of a creature and called. Lloyd then put on a benevolent smile toward it and said, “You better answer me what I’m about to ask, or else you’ll practice filial piety to your parents.”

“...!”

The demon’s eyes burned in rage when it heard a blessing from a complete stranger.

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Chapter: 230 Along with Money: Hell (3)

The main gate of Hell. Underneath the sky blackened with smoke, two pillars of blazing fire shot up, and a long passage led in between them. At the end of it, there was a skull that was as big as a mountain. It was the home of the King of Hell, as well as the center of the land, the Hell Castle. Demon Pagenti, a resident of Hell, smiled evilly as it pointed to the castle.

“That is not the Hell Castle,” Pagenti said.

“Yeah? All your words are lies, aren’t they? You rotten piece of a bastard,” Lloyd scolded.

“Hehe, did you think I’d thank you if you told me that?”

“Who cares if you thank me or not?”

“Hahaha, is that so?”

Demon Pagenti blurted out rude remarks one after another. However, contrasting its words, it cordially bowed to Lloyd. How could it not? The day before, when it met Lloyd for the first time, it was beaten up to a pulp. It could never forget what happened the other day.

It hurt like hell, dammit!

Pagenti was simply going its way, hungry after lazing around in the magma sauna, its home. It had come out of its home to pester and eat lost souls nearby. That was when a large parrotbill landed beside it and the human riding the bird suddenly gave the demon a blessing.

What was it he said? That I would have to practice filial piety toward my parents if I don’t answer his question properly?

This was a blessing that anyone in Hell would deplore and lament as soon as they heard it, the kind that insulted a demon’s personality to the core.

Practice filial piety to my parents?!

What kind of life did one have to live to be able to spit out such awful words? And did Pagenti seem like an easy enough target for Lloyd to give such a blessing without a second thought? Demon Pagenti burned in rage and revealed its fangs right there, rightfully so as a resident of Hell. It jumped at Lloyd with determination to exterminate the rude man and throw him alive into the flaming pits of Hell. But before it could succeed, the demon was slammed across its cheeks. A clear and melodious sound rang across the whole world.

Wham! The metal shovel struck down at lightning speed. Pagenti found its head jerking to the side when the flat shovel head whacked it. That was it for Pagenti. The whole world grew dark, and it passed out. When the demon opened its eyes, it found its attacker, Lloyd, grinning at it.

"Hello?"

"Wh-what's…"

Pagenti was about to ask what just happened, but before it could do so, the shovel struck down once more. *Wham!*

Once again, a clear, melodious sound rang aloud and the world darkened. That was when it started. Pagenti woke up. Lloyd grinned. And before Pagenti had the time to say anything, it received another strike. This pattern repeated ten more times. And on the 11th strike, Pagenti finally made a realization. So, it bowed down flat on the ground as soon as it woke up.

"Please forgive me. Stop it, please!" Pagenti begged earnestly. But Lloyd simply grinned with a glow of satisfaction.

"Then let's end it with one last strike!"

"...!"

There couldn't be anyone more heinous than this person, thought the demon. Even after Pagenti's sincere begging, Lloyd's shovel continued to

fly toward it. When Pagenti felt its head get shoved to the side by another blow, amid losing consciousness, it felt a shaft of despair and thought inwardly that it had been a while since it met such a deeply evil individual. He was truly a respectable man. The demon teared up in sincere admiration. And so, when Pagenti opened its eyes again, it was already prepared to pledge its loyalty to Lloyd. From that moment, Pagenti became Lloyd's dutiful tour guide.

"Hahaha, do you plan on flying to the twisted mountain, Master Lloyd?"

"Mhm," drawled Lloyd.

"My, how wise you are. Yes, that's right. That's the Hell Castle."

"Is it? If that's not the castle, I'll fry you in magma as a reward. How does that sound?" growled Lloyd.

"Please don't."

"Then? Where is it?"

"The truth is, that twisted mountain... Haah, it's a mirage." At last, Pagenti revealed.

"Tsk. My suspicion was correct. Then there's got to be the real one somewhere, right?" asked Lloyd.

"Yes."

"Where is it?"

"..."

"Do you want to die?"

"To be honest, the Hell Castle is at... Over the lava lake... Blah blah blah... Past the western ash pile... Yada yada... Over the skeleton bin... That's where it is."

“Wow. And you planned on lying, pretending you don’t know?”

“Yes.”

“Was it worth it?”

“Yes.”

“How about now that you spilled the truth?”

“I am in agony...”

“Tsk. It must be just so hard to tell the truth.”

“Yes...” Pagenti replied, choking up.

“It’s okay. Cheer up, you bastard. Once you’re done guiding me around, I’ll insult you as a reward.”

“Do you really mean it?”

“Of course.”

And so, the conversation took off in such a manner for the past day, and Pagenti finally succeeded in guiding them to the real Hell Castle.

Wow, not lying for a day was an ordeal.

Of course, Pagenti did lie at times. But it told the truth more often than not, making Pagenti feel a pang of guilt in its conscience. But it held up because it was no other than Lloyd, the notorious “Hell’s Singer.” He was the very person who destroyed the eardrums of Sir Giolexius the commander of the 1st Corps. And guiding this heinous man would bring honor to three generations of its family. Demon Pagenti turned around to look at Lloyd, feeling a sense of pride.

“Um, since my guide ends here-”

“Are you asking for an insult?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes!”

Demon Pagentani’s eyes glimmered. An insult from the Lloyd? Pagentani wished to permanently ingrain his words in its ears or frame them on a wall. But Lloyd destroyed Pagentani’s excitement in one moment.

“I don’t want to,” dismissed Lloyd.

“Excuse me...?” Pagenti’s eyes widened.

“Wait, did you expect me to keep my promise?” Lloyd taunted.

“Ha, t-that means-”

“The promise I made with you means less to me than a chewed-up piece of gum.”

“Oh! Oh! Oh!” exclaimed Pagentani.

“Did you get it...?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes...”

“Then piss off. I don’t want you in my sight.”

“Thank you so much!” Demon Pagentani ran away, its face beaming with a smile.

Lloyd sighed as he looked at the back of it.

Goodness, demons...

Being insulted enthralled them. And being lied to along with it, had them rolling on the ground in excitement.

Seriously, they’d love internet forums in Korea.

It was a haven for slander and insults. The very place where users put down each other on a regular basis and threw insults at one’s personality. Though

the atmosphere was different for each website, users' trash-talking and humiliating people was generally a daily occurrence across Korean social media. But here in this place called Hell, it seemed everyone would be able to easily adjust to the internet.

Well, anyway,

Lloyd stared at the main gate of Hell Castle with a shrug. He had finally arrived here after taking advantage of one demon. So now...

"You cannot be meeting the King of Hell like this," interrupted Javier, who had been silently following behind Lloyd all this time.

Lloyd turned and looked at Javier, his face saying, "Why bother to ask something so obvious?"

"I am," Lloyd spoke with a grin.

But Javier's face stiffened. "I believe your plan is too dangerous and careless."

"Dangerous and careless?" Lloyd cocked his head to the side. "Why?"

"He is the King of Hell."

Lloyd, however, ignored him and moved toward the entrance. He soon pointed out, "The King rules over Hell. We have no way of knowing what power he holds. Therefore, your safety is in question. That is, even if I cultivated a new level of power."

"Do you mean you're nervous even though you're now a grandmaster?" asked Lloyd.

"Yes," Javier admitted without any bit of shame in his voice.

"And that's because you don't know what kind of person he is?"

"Yes."

“In that case, it’s fine,” assured Lloyd.

“Excuse me?”

Javier flinched. Lloyd shrugged.

“You may not know this, but the King of Hell is the least dangerous fellow in all of Hell.”

“I am not sure what you mean...”

“Don’t worry about it. I have a plan, so just relax and follow me.”

Lloyd chuckled in spite of himself. The thing was, he could always summon an exit gate from Hell if things really got dangerous and transport them back to the Lorasian continent. He could return to his ordinary life and give up on this mission without any regret. There wasn’t much pressure on him. So, Lloyd relentlessly walked forward without any hesitation as he entered the main castle, as though he was strolling around the Frontera manor. Just then, a passage from the novel naturally came to him.

There was a mention of the King of Hell in The Knight of Blood and Iron.

The King of Hell. The ruler of Hell. The commander ruling over all Hell’s Knights. Most would envision him to look so destructive when they hear those titles. But in reality, he was very different. Lloyd continued to walk as he recalled that part, and he made his entrance to the main palace of Hell Castle.

Since Lloyd wasn’t a soul yet but a living person with flesh, he was a stranger in this realm of the world. So his appearance brought surprised murmurs from the guards, who whispered to themselves if that man was indeed the master singer Lloyd Frontera. Lloyd ignored and continued to stride to the center of the castle, finally toward the throne of the King of Hell. Lloyd paid his respect to the king, who was sitting on a throne that looked much like an office chair. And the desk was wide but bare, without any decorations. Piles of paper took up the desk, and the king looked like he’d soon drown under the paper heaps. Pale and fatigued, the king fidgeted

his rimmed glasses and muttered as he looked at the one paying respect to him. There was annoyance in his gesture.

“Haah, what now when I’m so busy...?” the King of Hell murmured.

The King of Hell. The one who could see through the core of anyone’s soul. The master of karma, and the watcher of the 19th purgatory. He was Hellkaros, the King of Hell.

“Haah,” grumbled Hellkaros, “For what reason have you barged in here when I am swamped with an endless amount of work? Can you not see that I have been unable to get off work for the past 670,000 years?”

“Please forgive me, the ruler of Hell,” said Lloyd respectfully. “Lloyd Frontera from the ground pays his respects to the king.”

“Respect, my foot. Suho Kim. We’ve met, haven’t we?”

The King of Hell’s question stung Lloyd, who flinched when he heard his real name. And Lloyd cast a glance at Javier to check for any change in the latter’s expression. Thankfully, it looked like Javier didn’t know yet the real meaning of “Suho Kim.” Trying to look natural and undisturbed, Lloyd looked up at the king.

“Yes, we have met,” answered Lloyd. “You appeared in my dream.”

It was true. The giant in fire. This king had once appeared in Lloyd’s dream in all of his stateliness. He had considered it a lively silly dream back then, but now, it turned out that the dream was real.

“I am truly guilty for paying a visit to you amid this time when you are busy giving verdicts in Hell. May I then get to business right away?”

“Of course. Hurry up.”

The King of Hell swayed his hands as if he couldn’t be bothered. All this while his gaze went back to the paper, his one hand grasping the pen and signing documents. With his other hand, he was flipping the papers as he

even stamped them. Yes. This was the real image and essence of the King of Hell.

He's a workaholic. A judge that judges hundreds, billions, and trillions of dead souls. He's piled under a mountain of work, so he punished the others only with formal documents and the rule of law.

Just then, Lloyd recalled a part in *The Knight of Blood and Iron* that spoke about the essence of the King of Hell. He was said to never take part in direct combat. And he killed no entity. Documents and judgments. Those two weapons were the only ones he wielded to determine the fate of the others.

In other words, the work that required any use of force was left to Hell's Knights and their corps, while he glued himself to the desk of never-reducing paper works to exact judgment on people. That was what the novel said about the King of Hell. And so, he had the least chance of posing any harm to Lloyd so long he wasn't set for an official judgment in Hell. There was zero chance of offending the king during the conversation and dying or getting hurt. And so, literally speaking, this king was the safest brother here. That was the reason why Lloyd was able to maintain such composure about meeting the king.

Really, the scarier one is Hell's Knight, not the King of Hell.

But there was Javier to save Lloyd from Hell's Knight, for Javier has become a grandmaster. So long five or six Hell's Knights don't jump at him at once, he'd be able to put up a fight. But if things really seemed like Javier would be outnumbered and cornered in danger, Lloyd could always use the exit gate out of Hell and run away to the ground. He had done the math and concluded that he'd be safe even if he went to Hell. And it was primarily due to that conclusion and conviction that made Lloyd accept Anticus's request.

And so, now that he had met the King of Hell at last, it was time to go back home after finishing his business quickly. Go back home, get an audience with the Dragon King Verkis, and enjoy the benefits of being in the Dragon

King club. Resolving such determination in his mind, Lloyd wet his lips and spoke aloud the clever comment he had prepared for this moment.

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Chapter 231: Hell Express 666 (1)

“Tell me, don’t you wish to get off work?”

The moment Lloyd uttered those words, the King of Hell put a sudden halt to his pen that had been moving at lightning speed.

“What?” The King of Hell shot a cynical glare toward Lloyd. He wondered if this was what it would look like if ice could glare.

But Lloyd wasn’t intimidated. After all, he saw this response coming.

Of course. He’s been working overtime for 670,000 years. How else would he answer whether he wants to go home?

His response was obvious.

“It goes without saying that I do,” huffed the king. “Why are you asking such an obvious question?”

Hellkaros’s voice was rough and on edge, and he had a face that said, “You kidding me?” Lloyd saw it as a good sign. This was better than a while ago when he simply buried his face in paperwork without giving a single glance to Lloyd. At least right now, he had the chance to strike a deal.

“I think I can help you with that,” Lloyd responded.

“Help me?” Hellkaros frowned. “You?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“I will tell you once you give me the promise to release the soul of dragon Anticus who is under your confinement right now.”

And with that, Lloyd clamped his mouth shut, staring only at the king with a meaningful gaze. Their eyes locked, and a moment later...

“Ha.” King Hellkaros scoffed before saying, “Are you striking a deal with me?”

“Yes, I am.”

“How dare you. What are you thinking?”

“I heard that you are after extreme efficiency and fairness in all things, My Lord.”

“You did?” asked the king.

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded his head. It was true. He did hear about the king. Where? In the novel.

There was a brief mention of him. The book wrote that the King of Hell uses the rule of law to punish the dead. But he started to chase after efficiency as his work became overwhelmingly hectic. And so...

The king demanded a fair cost for everything. Nothing was free for him. In order to receive a favor from him, you had to pay the proper price.

Just perfect. I like how he thinks. How can I not? Life is all about give and take in the first place.

There were no such things like free lunch or charity. King Hellkaros was similar to Lloyd in that sense. And so, throughout his travel to meet the king, Lloyd placed himself in the king’s shoes. How would the king react when Lloyd suggested releasing the soul of the dragon? Thinking from the king’s perspective, the answer came immediately.

I’d scoff, saying that the dragon can’t be freed without a cost. This would prompt the suggesting party to plead and beg me to name a price for the dragon’s release. I can’t do that. If I did, then the king would have the upper hand right from the beginning.

If possible, it was best to begin all negotiations by making the other party plead. That was a good way to get a strong start in the war of negotiation. Lloyd thought of it as a fight for dominance. And so, he was able to devise a strategy customized just for the King of Hell, who was chronically overworked. Lloyd first caught the king's attention by throwing a bait; in other words, he mentioned there was a way for him to get off work. And taking advantage of the moment, he subtly brought up his request by saying he would tell him how he could get off work if he released dragon Anticus.

"How does that sound?" asked Lloyd. "If you give me your promise, I will be able to tell you my secret method."

"..."

Lloyd flashed a grin, and the king frowned, his brows forming a wrinkle in the forehead. Lloyd Frontera, no, Suho Kim truly was a nasty person with his cunning and sly ways. Hellkaros had felt that way the last time the latter eliminated Sir Giolexius, that is, Hell's Knight. But at the same time, Lloyd became more desirable to the king the longer he watched him.

Should I just make him take my place?

At first, the plan was to make him sing and become the speaker for Hell's broadcast since his terrible singing seemed suitable to punish the dead in purgatory. That was why he made an effort and used his precious time to appear in Lloyd's dream. But now, Hellkaros's had a slight change of heart. If only he could, he wanted to throw every bit of his responsibility onto Lloyd's plate. He appeared more than competent enough in his job to allow Hellkaros to rest for tens of thousands of years.

But he soon shook his head. It was realistically impossible. In order for his dream to materialize, he would have to renounce his position to this human. Or, grant him enough power to serve as his substitute. Neither of those two options was very appealing.

Well, the dragon's soul has the same worth as a rare goldfish ornament to me.

As such, he would just feel slightly regretful about letting the dragon go. There wouldn’t be any significant loss for him. And then what would he get in return? He would be able to get off work and get back his life in the evening.

Gulp. The King of Hell swallowed involuntarily. He would be liberated from his mountain of paperwork. He could throw away his stifling necktie. He could leisurely enjoy a glass of highly acidic juice as he bathed in a volcanic hot spring. After he refreshed himself, he could relax in bed and catch up on the novels, legends, and other tales he missed in the last 670,000 years. At this point in his train of thought, he had found his answer.

Though a part of him was slighted because this Suho seemed to know his needs very well, the suggestion was a very appealing one. And so, at last, the king made a decision.

“All right. I promise.”

“Truly, My Lord?” Lloyd beamed.

“Indeed. I promise to release the soul of Anticus. So, tell me. Tell me the secret to getting off work and away from all my responsibilities.”

“Your Majesty has to trust me with one construction project. That’s all,” Lloyd answered.

“Construction?”

“Yes.”

The king’s grimace deepened. A smile appeared on Lloyd’s mouth.

My plan worked.

Lloyd secretly clenched his fists. Just as he expected, the King of Hell showed a positive response.

I knew this would work. In the end, this exchange is a win for both of us.

The King of Hell could work less and enjoy his evenings when he was off duty. As for Lloyd, he would eventually obtain the funding of Dragon King Verkis, endless treasures, and an extra life by freeing Anticus's soul from Hell.

All of this can happen if I successfully complete one construction project.

Lloyd licked his lips. The sweet life he had dutifully built in his fiefdom would be free from ruin with endless treasures. And he'd be able to enjoy himself more as he'd have one more shot in life. His dream of becoming a happy, carefree bum would come true.

With such ambition in his head, Lloyd spoke, "Let me ask you one question, My King. Is there anyone in Hell who can replace your position as a judge?"

"No, there isn't."

"Then are you unable to get off work because you have too much on your plate?" asked Lloyd.

"No, it is not that." The King of Hell shook his head. "I am the King of Hell and the judge of the deceased. Since I hold the power to bestow judgments on fallen souls, it does not make sense that I cannot get off work because there is too much. I can go home regardless of if I have dozens, hundreds, or even trillions of souls left to judge for the day."

Truly, it was almost impossible to count the number of judgments the King of Hell made in one day. The number of souls from deceased humans only represented a portion of the total number. Along with humans, all the animals and microorganisms on earth also had souls in their own special way. And the souls of these unicellular organisms and bacteria reached astronomical amounts. An astronomical number. Why? 40% of bacteria in the bottom of the ocean were killed by bacteriophage in the sea every day.

"Judging them is easy," the king continued to speak. "Their simple souls don't possess the same flaws as humans. So unlike the complicated human souls that are either sent to Heaven or Hell, these creatures don't require

much deliberation. I just need to lump together all their souls for the day and shove them into the Door of Resurrection, which sits at the edge of Hell. To do that, I just need to confer one judgment. However...”

The King of Hell, who lifted his pen, smiled bitterly.

“The problem is transferring the souls from this castle to the very edge of Hell. Wait, did you hear about this on your way here?” asked Hellkaros.

“Yes, I did, to be honest.”

Lloyd nodded. It was true. He heard from Pagenti, the demon Lloyd had thrashed to get to this castle.

“I heard that there’s a huge number of souls that need to be transported, but the road isn’t paved properly yet. I heard that the road cannot be paved because of the lava boiling across the land.”

“Yes, you are right. That is the reason why I am tied to this desk. To be more correct, it is because I supervise it,” corrected the king.

“You are busy because you are setting the transportation route, which changes every day depending on the road conditions.”

The King of Hell heaved a sigh. Since roads melted in lava every day, the transportation route had to be changed accordingly. He had to oversee it in real time and inspect it. His back broke, setting a new transportation route every day, every hour. Nothing changed even when he entrusted the job to the demons under him.

“I get reports almost every minute from the demons in the field pulling the carriage of the souls. Reports that the transportation route is blocked. That it melted in the lava. That the carriage can’t be passed. That a new path must be recommended. But when I do that, a similar report comes up a few minutes later. And then I have to open a new route again. Do you know how many demons are working to drive the carriage? 800,000.”

Lloyd couldn’t say anything. So he kept listening.“It’s a terribly onerous job,” the king went on. “800,00 demons clamor and make reports and demand almost every minute. Plus, the only one who can exert strong control over the demons in Hell is me. No one else. And do you know what happens if I fall behind on my work and the carriage gets delayed? Catastrophe. No questions about that.”

“By that, you mean-”

“If I fail to put the souls of the bacteria in the Door of Resurrection, most of them won’t be able to resurrect when they support the entire ecosystem on this planet. Cell division will stop. More will die, while those coming to life will be few. The microbial food chain will completely break down. Can you guess what the aftermath will be?”

“Well, the entire planet will face massive extinction, I suppose,” postulated Lloyd.

“That’s exactly right. And that is why I’ve been working nonstop for 670,000 years.”

“Um,” mused Lloyd, “then how were things 670,000 years ago?”

“How else? The same as now.”

“The same?”

“My predecessor worked just like I did.”

“Do you mean there was a king before you?” asked Lloyd, slightly befuddled.

“Yes. The previous King of Hell. He eventually committed suicide after struggling with depression from being unable to go home for 38 billion years.”

“...”

Lloyd had no words to say. The smile on the King’s face grew much more bitter.

“That’s what is at stake when you declare that you can solve this problem. So, what project is this? What construction project can solve this awful transportation issue?”

The king’s voice seemed to be laden with bitterness and resentment. Lloyd shuddered at the question.

Woah. I heard that there was an issue transporting souls from Pagenti, but this is...

As the problem was brought to the table, it turned out to be much more serious and risky than Lloyd expected. It was about a delivery system that carried the fate of an entire planet. Well, that didn’t matter to Lloyd. He had tried to find a solution the moment he speculated what the issue was. On his journey to this castle, he searched for and found a solution.

“To dare to tell you the answer, Your Majesty...” Lloyd paused. He then looked up, looking straight into the king. “Why don’t you put up a railroad?”

“A railroad?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded his head.

The king narrowed his eyes. “Railroad? An object that exists in the world of Suho Kim.”

“Oh, yes...” murmured Lloyd, shuddering. The constant mention of his real name agitated him because he kept minding Javier beside him. Lloyd feared that Javier would grow suspicious. But he shook off his feelings of agitation as his attention was needed on more important matters. He was in the process of negotiating with the King of Hell over a construction project. Furthermore, it was almost time for a decision to be made from their negotiation.

Focus.

Lloyd collected his breath. Now was the crucial moment. He had to effectively inform the King of Hell in detail about the ups of putting up a railroad in Hell and how it will solve the soul transportation issue. No, he had to brainwash the king. Really well.

Whew, this is a presentation. Yes. A presentation before a professor.

Every presentation began by hooking the attention of the audience. That required a strong, creative name to gain traction. Finally, having determined his strategy, Lloyd lifted his head. He looked straight into the king's eyes with a confident gaze.

"Allow me to introduce the 'Hell Express 666' project."

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Chapter 232: Hell Express 666 (2)

The history of the railroad was long. Surprisingly long. Similar to the endless connection of cars in a long train, the history of the railroad was much longer than what people would expect.

It really is. If I date back to the earliest history of railroads, it starts all the way from 600 BC.

Around 600 BC, there was a carriage road on the coast of Corinth, Greece. There was something different about this road compared to most others. The ground on the road had two furrows along it, and the distance between the furrows was identical to the size of carriage wheels. Thus, this road possessed the distinguishing feature of railroads with wheels that traveled along a line of designated tracks.

That's not all. There are other similar cases.

There was another similar case around 400 AD in the Eastern Roman Empire. What was more, a track with buried furrows was even discovered far east of the Eurasia Continent in Ancient China.

It was the Warring State period. The tracks were used to mobilize large crates of supply during these endless days of war. It was also found that each country's tracks had different sizes of wheels to prevent any enemies from using them when they invaded their land.

Just like that, humanity discovered the basic principle behind railroads in their early years of history. When these rudimentary railroad designs met the ripples of industrialization, the modern railroad came about to alter the history of human civilization altogether.

It's the advance guard of industrialization. And the impetus that enabled development along with the large-scale manufacturing industry. It also served as the foundation for war. Railroads can be found anywhere throughout history.

It was true. Humanity enjoyed all sorts of transportation methods, such as cars, ships, airplanes, and many others, but nothing came close to being as efficient as the trains. Cars? Try driving around Seoul, and go figure. For long travel across large towns or cities, most people would prefer taking a subway over a bus. In fact, one would be able to fully experience the comfort of a train by taking a train ride from Seoul to Busan. What about ships?

It can transport large numbers of crates at once. That's a clear advantage. However, a ship is limited by how it can't move without water.

And so, ships couldn't be used as the main method of transportation within a country's border.

The same goes for planes.

First off, it was too expensive. And due to the weight-sensitive nature of airplanes' landing and take-off, it was impossible to carry a lot of cargo at once. Plus, it was vulnerable to storms and other inclement weather conditions. Thus, each transportation method had its ups and downs. However, trains were...

In terms of efficiency, it's almost perfect.

That was what Lloyd believed. Trains could carry large amounts of cargo at once similar to ships. Traffic was not a concern for trains, unlike cars. Trains also didn't stop just because the weather was bad like planes. To top it all off, it was affordable, precise, and massive. These were all large advantages for trains.

"However, the initial costs of building a railroad and its infrastructure are costly, so it's a matter of whether you can afford the price," explained Lloyd.

"Do you mean the price to construct what you called a railroad?" asked the King of Hell.

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded and plastered a confident smile. “But I’m sure the Hell Castle won’t have any problem shouldering the cost.”

“You are right, but...” The king knitted his brows slightly. “Railroad. Efficient transportation. I understand everything. But how do you plan on setting it up here?”

“Do you ask,” Lloyd mused, “because of the flowing lava?”

“Indeed.” The frown on the king’s face deepened. “You said it. The railroad involves processing steel and laying them down on the ground. But the tracks will likely melt before long on the grounds of hell filled with pockets of lava everywhere.”

“Yes, that is certain.” Lloyd’s voice didn’t shake a bit.

“Then you have a plan?”

“Of course.”

“Tell me.”

“It’s a business secret.”

“Not because you lack confidence?”

“If you can’t believe me, then you don’t have to entrust this job with me.”

“...”

The King of Hell, Hellkaros, stared down at Lloyd, trying to make sense of the human in front of him.

Suho Kim.

Hellkaros could see through the core of someone’s soul, so he was somewhat aware of Lloyd’s real identity. At least he knew that Suho Kim belonged to another world and ended up here for some inexplicable reason. So, Hellkaros regarded Suho as a laughable and absurd figure. But at the

same time, he was intrigued. Why? While it was laughable that Lloyd was running wild when he was just a soul from another world buttressing the affairs of this world and making such bold conditions for him, it was interesting to hear about this railroad. His interest was piqued.

What he explained... can solve the problem here in Hell.

The King of Hell thought about it. The advantages and disadvantages of the railroad. The issues those advantages could solve.

It's possible. That is if what he said is true.

A train would be formed by lining up hundreds of carts. And to generate power for the train, he simply needed to connect pulleys and levers to the wheels, assigning dozens of demons to push and pull the lever by taking shifts. It'd be like rowing a boat, only with levers. The train would move using the demons' strength.

That would allow me to reduce the number of demons I need while transporting souls. Even with just 8000 demons, I would be able to transport a similar number of souls as now using 80,000 demons.

Hellkaros earnestly did the math. Transporting souls would require much fewer demons. And the leftover demons could maintain the railroad. Even so, there'd still be those who had no work to do.

Then they can assist with my work.

Hell Castle had a plethora of menial jobs inside it. Assisting with the king's judgments. Organizing records of the good and bad deeds of souls. Distributing queue numbers to the souls waiting to be judged. Dividing souls bound for Hell, Heaven, and Purgatory after their verdict.

I'll give those chores to them all. My own workload will also get substantially lighter. I won't have to continually find a new transportation route for those idiotic demons with a reliable railroad. If that happens...

He would be liberated from every single one of his miscellaneous chores. All that was left for him to do was sentence dead souls, a basic task for him. And that meant...

I can get off work.

Thump! Hellkaros's heartbeat vigorously sped up. He could go home. After 670,000 years. Away from his sickening work. He could finally activate the door lock to his house, which still had a protective film on. He could finally open the door to his house, remove his dress shoes, dip himself in a warm lava bath, and binge-watch TV shows with his mana-powered marble. HellTube. Hellflix. Hellcha. Hellver Series.

I've never spent a day of my life like that before.

Gulp. The mere thought of it made his heart thump. It was exhilarating and thrilling to just think about it. And there was one more benefit to this. Liberation from anxiety. A sense of crippling anxiety gripped Hellkaros that he might meet the same fate as his predecessor, who ended his own life from depression after overworking for 3.8 billion years. And there was the despair that such fate was unavoidable. All these years, such feelings haunted him. But now, the dark cloud of anxiety and despair that shrouded his heart for the longest time started to thin out. That was probably why Hellkaros stared at Lloyd differently and why he put on a content smile, unlike a while ago.

"I like that."

"Yes, so that means-"

"Suho Kim, I will trust you and leave the railroad construction to you," announced Hellkaros.

"Thank you!" Lloyd hung his head down. He always welcomed new clients. And now, it was time to...

"Time to sign the construction contract?" Hellkaros asked first.

“My, that would make me the happiest man in the world,” said Lloyd as he smiled and rubbed his hands, inwardly praising the king. He indeed was the icon of fair judgment and negotiation. Lloyd admired how the king first suggested writing a contract even when he didn’t say anything.

This kind of client is so convenient to work with.

Satisfied, Lloyd said, “Oh, there is one thing I must ask of you.”

“Ask of me?”

“Yes, and it’s something essential I need from you for this project.”

“What is it?” asked Hellkaros.

“It’s simple. Please spread the news throughout the land that Lloyd Frontera will be singing at the edge of Hell,” revealed Lloyd.

“Hmm, that won’t be difficult to do. You say this is essential for the construction?”

“Yes, it’s essential to make the construction run smoothly. In the first place, I doubt you have any plans to set aside a group of demon workers for me.”

“That is obvious. The obedient ones are already transporting souls. The others are as good as trash, slacking off and threatening to end their lives should they be put to work. Could you possibly be thinking of trying to use them?”

“Yes, that is what I intend to do.”

“Then I see. I shall send a public announcement throughout Hell,” Hellkaros promised.

“Thank you.”

Everything after that took place smoothly. Lloyd drew up the construction contract like usual. The job was laying the railroad in the areas Hellkaros requested. Then Hellkaros was to release the soul of Anticus after the

construction. Those were the terms written in the contract. Since the terms were simple, there weren't any adjustments to make. Once the two checked the content of the contract, each signed and took one copy. That was it.

"Good," said Hellkaros with a smile. "I am glad that we made a final contract, at least. I wasted at least 20 minutes listening to your explanation on the railroad and signing this contract."

"By waste, you mean-"

"That is how long the carriage has been delayed," explained Hellkaros nonchalantly. "And how long the propagation of the microorganisms on earth has been delayed."

"..."

"Let us say the chance for grand extinction on earth has increased by one percent due to the broken microbial ecosystem."

"Eeek," gasped Lloyd.

"It's nothing to be surprised about. Okay, so the contract is made, so I will send you to the construction site right away."

"To the site?"

"Yes. I will get you there right away as you will be wasting time on your travels otherwise."

The King of Hell gestured, and a red ripple appeared. It soon spread and wrapped Lloyd and Javier's bodies.

"You will find yourself at the edge of Hell," explained Hellkaros. "Construct the railroad from there until you get here. Well then, I shall see you again when the railroad is finished."

And with that...

Zap!

“...!”

The red ripple that engulfed them beamed and flashed like an explosion. Everything around them became dark. Lloyd felt like his whole body was floating in the air. After his stomach churned for a moment, he felt his feet touch the strange ground. *Thwack!*

“Woah.”

Lloyd blinked hard. His whole surrounding had changed after some quick thrashing. The Hell Castle had disappeared from his view along with the King of Hell. To be exact...

“I suppose this is the edge of Hell the king spoke of,” said Javier.

“Yes, I agree.”

Lloyd felt a small rush of relief when he heard Javier beside him.

The king must have transported us here. After all, Hell is his territory.

Lloyd surveyed straight ahead. The ash-covered plain was devoid of even a strand of grass. There was sulfur-scented smoke rising from scattered spots. Lloyd also spotted a lava pond still soft and unhardened. The scenery was Hell itself, desolate and barren. But the opposing side was slightly different.

“I guess this is the edge of Hell,” Lloyd said.

“It appears so, indeed,” Javier seconded.

Lloyd watched the landscape of the edge of Hell. It was an open cliff whose depth couldn’t be measured. There was nothing but a dark void ahead.

I can’t even imagine what would happen if I fell down there.

Lloyd shivered, taking 30 steps back from the cliff, as he resolved to never fall from it. Just then, he heard Javier speak.

“Master Lloyd, I have a question.”

“A question?” Lloyd looked at Javier.

“Yes.”

“What is it?”

“Who is Suho Kim?”

“Cough...! Ergh!” Lloyd spluttered, choking on his own saliva.

“Are you okay, Young Master?” Javier asked with a frown.

“Ah, yeah. My throat got dry. It’s the air here. Terrible.”

“...”

Lloyd feigned and half-joked. But Javier didn’t smile.

“I kept thinking about it, and yet, it is still strange. The king a while ago. The king kept addressing you with a strange name, ‘Suho Kim.’” Javier looked at Lloyd with a curious face.

“Oh, that?” said Lloyd, stressing his voice to sound calm.

“Yes.”

“I know, right? That was just strange. Don’t you think so?” Lloyd said with equal, feigned curiosity in his voice.

“Yes, you clearly have a name. Lloyd Frontera. Then I suppose you are unaware of what that address means to you?”

“Of course, I don’t. How would I know? Well, it’s probably a nickname used in Hell or something,” speculated Lloyd. And he shrugged.

“Is that so?” Javier asked dully.

“Yeah, like I said.”

“I see.”

“Probably?”

Lloyd then plastered a grin, making sure that the corners of his lips didn’t shiver awkwardly and that his thumping heart wouldn’t give him away. He pretended to be ignorant and made an effort to look calm. At the same time, he also didn’t forget to bash the king inwardly.

Shoot. That was close. That King of Hell is so evil. Why did he have to call me by my real name? Goodness.

Lloyd decided that he should meet the king alone next time. Thankfully, Javier had another subject to discuss.

“By the way, I have one more question.”

“What again?”

“How on earth do you plan on constructing a railroad here?”

Javier pointed at the vast land covered with thick volcanic ash and stagnated with lava. The whole place boiled at a massively hot temperature.

“I, too, heard about the railroad when you explained it to the king. So, I have some understanding now. The crux of it was to put up a line of tracks that fit the size of a train’s wheels.”

“You’re right,” agreed Lloyd.

“But now that I see this place, I wonder if the railroad will be safe.”

“Oh, you are right about that, too. It’s truly reasonable that you ask it. Go on.”

“Yes, if we install the railroads made of steel, I think the road will melt because of the heat here. It will become malleable as it melts, and that means the trains will not be able to travel properly,” theorized Javier seriously.

“You are right. Plus, the ground for laying out the railroads will be pretty unstable because there’s lava everywhere,” added Lloyd on top of Javier’s explanation.

Javier frowned. “Then how on earth do you plan on going about the construction?”

“I have a plan.” Lloyd’s assurance, however, meant nothing to Javier.

“Wait, do you plan on scamming against the King of Hell?”

“Whaaat? Scamming the King of Hell?” gasped Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“How little do you think of me?” Lloyd asked with a smile.

Javier, on the other hand, looked grim. He reeled off, “A sly cheat. You are also cheap and rude. Sometimes, I wonder if a pathetic crook who does nothing but scheme like yourself can even be called a human being. Personally speaking.”

“...”

“Am I wrong?” Javier’s face looked innocent.

“You might as well just break one of my bones, you know.” Lloyd shook his head.

“I cannot let that happen,” Javier said defiantly. “Breaking your leg is an act of mutiny and violence.”

“Just so you know, there is this called ‘verbal violence.’”

“That seems to be the field of your expertise,” pointed out Javier.

“My, my. What an absurd remark against my young and innocent soul.”

“I do not know anything about being innocent or fresh, but I do know that you are so lucky with women.”

“Lucky with women? Me?” Lloyd looked at Javier with curiosity.

“Yes.”

“What are you saying?”

“No, sorry, Master Lloyd. I mean out of luck.”

“...”

“Anyway, I see you have a plan for how to build the railroad here.”

“Hey, don’t change the subject after beating me up with your words.”

“But I want to.” Javier shrugged.

“Woah.”

“Can I not change the subject?”

“Fine. Let’s change it. Sure. Haah.”

Lloyd broke into laughter. It was clear to Lloyd that Javier was enjoying this moment, and not enough with that, it was clear that he had not only gotten comfortable serving Lloyd but learned how to enjoy himself doing it.

Dammit. And it’s not like I can strike him.

Lloyd decided inwardly to revenge him hundreds of times more severely someday. He then shifted his focus to the matter at hand.

“So, I guess you want to know how the railroad will be built here?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes, I am.”

“Well, it’s simple.” Lloyd grinned. “First, we need to rally the tens of thousands of unemployed demons living all across Hell,” Lloyd then added, revealing the first step of the plan to build the Hell Express 666.

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Chapter 233: Demons Must Be Abused (1)

“What? Master Singer Lloyd Frontera is at the center of Hell?”

About ten demons were relaxing in a lava bath in the capital region near the Hell Castle. Among them, one demon created more stress for its parents today as usual. Another one was the cause behind the deepening wrinkles of its parents. The gathered demons placed an immense burden on their parents through various acts of evil. Normally, they boasted about their depravities and exploits to each other, but today was a bit different. There was a more refreshing topic for them to discuss.

“Lloyd Frontera?”

“Wait, the rumored man of Hell’s Singer?”

“I heard Sir Giolexius passed out listening to his singing.”

“Hahaha. How could he not?” The one-horned demon, who brought the news to the group, grinned. “You all felt it. How the gate of Hell opened up.”

“Oh, yes, I did.”

“Then you must have felt that very man we are praising set his foot inside Hell.”

“That I did, too. But you’re saying he’s at the center of Hell?”

“Yeah.” The one-horned demon nodded. “I guess you’re slow to the news? The King of Hell announced it this morning.”

“Is that actually true?”

“Of course.”

“Really?”

“Do you really think I’d lie about an announcement from the king?”

“Well. You wouldn’t.”

“Of course not. So, trust me.”

“Good. I will trust you. So, let’s go hear the master sing! To the edge of Hell!”

“But I just said that Lloyd Frontera is at the center of Hell,” the one-horned demon corrected.

“That’s why we’re heading to the edge.”

“Why?”

“Think in my shoes. Will you trust every word you say if you were me?”

“...”

“Let’s go! To the end!”

All of the demons chilling in the lava bath jumped to their feet and set on the journey to the edge after packing up. But this instance didn’t take place only here. All sorts of demons learned about Lloyd’s news near the castle, on the side of a nameless volcano, and in Purgatory. And everyone began to travel to the end of Hell with one purpose in mind.

He is said to be the master in singing. And everyone praises him. So I’ve got to check how awful his singing is. And if his singing is even slightly different from the rumor...

The demons vowed to hurl insults at him. Nitpick even the slightest fault. Lay into him to the point he’d want to die. They resolved to destroy Lloyd’s reputation as the master of singing because he was better than all of them for no reason. A man unqualified like him must be brought to the ground to make them feel better even a little. They decided to pull his hair and make him fall.

Wahaha. Get ready.

The demons evilly waited for the opportunity to come. Lloyd Frontera? Hell's voice? The singer of the century? Their stomachs flipped every time they heard those rumors. They couldn't wrap their heads around why a man, who seemed to be mediocre just like them, should be respected and praised. They were much better than a puny man like Frontera. It was just evident that this moronic world didn't recognize their talents. All they needed was one chance, and they could be more famous than this Lloyd. That was the only explanation behind their misfortune and lack of fame. Some day, they'd rise above their current position and show their true talents. But first, it required dragging down this undeservingly respected man and making one thing right in their idiotic world. All of them had the same thought, each engulfed by a wave of jealousy, competitiveness, and envy. Over 30,000 unemployed demons rushed to the end of Hell.

When Javier saw the spectacle of demons gathering around, he gasped, "Is... this why you asked the King of Hell to cooperate?"

"Yeah, of course." Lloyd nodded.

"Did you see this from the start?"

"Yeah, of course."

Standing on top of a sharp rock, Lloyd shrugged as he looked down at the 30,000 demons assembled below the rock.

Perfect.

This was beyond his expectation. It was a great success. He smiled satisfyingly like a farmer during harvest season, as he looked at the crowd.

"Think about it," Lloyd continued, "where are we?"

"Hell."

"How do you think demons would react when they hear the news of a famous and acclaimed man?"

“Did you think they’d be jealous and envious?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, you are correct.” Lloyd chuckled. “I figured that they’d run down here to slander me. The result is this.”

Lloyd pointed at the plain.

Woooo! 30,000 demons responded when they saw Lloyd’s gesture. Their rough cry filled the plain. First, they yelled out whatever they wanted until sometime later, their shouts evolved into one unified cry.

“Sing a song! Now!”

Their urge was threatening, and their gaze was hostile. The energy in the demon crowd grew fiercer. Lloyd smiled meaningfully as he looked at them from above. He cupped his hands together and pressed them to his mouth. Then activated the Asrahan Core Technique. The sound of his dry cough was amplified about ten times louder than normal through his hand trumpet and rang aloud across the plain.

“Hmm! Hmm! Ehem!”

The moment the noise hit their ears, the loud clamoring in the plain deafened as every demon shut their mouth. Tens of thousands of gazes focused on Lloyd. They waited in anticipation for Lloyd to sing and hoped to nitpick his skill. When their desire and anticipation reached their peak, Lloyd put on a mischievous smile.

“Come on, did you guys gather here because you thought I’d sing for you?”

“...!”

Everyone flinched. Lloyd continued to speak in a nonchalant manner.

“But I don’t want to sing for you!”

“...”

“Why should I do that?” Lloyd raised his hands, his palms looking up.

“...”

“Any strong reason why I should sing for you?” Lloyd’s voice was now brazen.

“That’s nonsense!” One of the one-horned demons yelled, provoked. “We traveled all the way to this place! To hear you sing!”

“Sure, but so?”

“And you won’t sing? That’s not making any sense!” The demon cried out again.

“Oh, yes, it does.”

“What...?”

“Why should I sing just because you all gathered here?” Lloyd asked back with a smug smile.

“B-but still!” the same demon replied, not knowing what to say. “The King of Hell made the announcement that you’ll sing here!”

“Yeah. But I just canceled it.”

“...”

“You guys are so pathetic for gathering up here just to hear a song that won’t help your life at all. Don’t you think so? Everyone must have a lot of free time.”

‘“...”

“And besides, did I make a promise that I’d do it?” defended Lloyd. “No, I didn’t. So, why are you demanding for me to sing? I decide whether I want to sing or not. That’s my decision. Don’t you agree?”

“...”

“So, I’m not singing,” announced Lloyd.

“No! But still!”

“You think this is unfair?”

“Of course!” One of them yelped.

“Then let’s just say I scammed you all.”

“...”

“Oh, wait, will that make you feel worse?”

“...”

Rage boiled in their hearts. They glared up at Lloyd, their gaze holding a glint of anger. If they could, they wanted to rip this human into pieces. But that wasn’t possible because of the silver-haired knight by his side, who had taken down the commander of the 1st Corps, Hell’s Knight. Come at him, and ordinary demons like them would get slaughtered even if there were thousands or tens of thousands of them. Knowing this, Lloyd laughed at the demons shaking in anger.

“Is there something else I can help everyone with? Or can you all just not bring yourself to leave? I’m going to leave now to do something much more important than entertaining this crowd here. If you have a problem with it, then fight me. Or else, piss off to where you came from and honor your parents.”

“...”

The demons silently seethed in anger. Leaving them alone, Lloyd walked down to the other end of the rock. Javier, who was waiting for him down here, frowned at Lloyd. His face showed signs of concern, which was unlike him.

“Um, Master Lloyd.”

“Eh? Why?”

“You rallied the demons in one place with the cooperation of the King of Hell,” he reminded, his voice still concerned.

“Yeah, uh-huh.” Lloyd nodded, picking up his ears.

“Then why did you treat them like that?”

“Hm?”

“We are not getting anything by treating them so heartlessly and coldly.”

“You think so?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes, I thought... that you would win their hearts with that awful singing of yours.”

“Then I’d use them as my workers?”

“Yes, so I am worried.”

“What are you worried about?”

“That they would hold hostile feelings against you and try to disturb our work.”

“Yeah, they definitely will.” Lloyd clapped his hands.

“Excuse me?”

“I said, they will definitely do it.”

“Then why did you still-”

“Do what I did?” put in Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“So that they’d disturb my work. That’s how I’ll get things moving.”

“Excuse me?”

“There’s no time to explain. Let’s get to work. Follow me.”

Lloyd motioned to Javier, who was still in a state of confusion. He took them to an area near the edge of Hell that he had eyed in advance. It was an open space with a boiling lava pond on one side.

“Okay, time to shovel.”

Thwack! Lloyd handed over a foldable shovel after bringing it out from his backpack. And he grabbed another one. Javier cocked his head to the side.

“Are you going to dig here?” asked Javier.

“Yes.”

“But for what?”

“Hunting.”

“Excuse me?”

“Hoards of hunting game will barge in this place for a few days.”

“Hunting-”

“Don’t worry about it. The hunting games will provide us with the key material for this project.”

“...”

Javier stared at Lloyd with a strange gaze, thinking to himself that Lloyd was truly a mysterious man he couldn’t understand. He even wanted to look into this young master’s head if he could. The smile Lloyd made as he looked at Javier was equally mysterious. It was as if he had already foreseen the future.

“Don’t look at me like that.”

“...”

“I’m not a prophet, and none of my ancestors were a fortuneteller. What I’m doing purely came from racking my head and thinking ahead.”

“...”

“So, come and dig now.”

“Yes.”

Javier couldn’t put a finger on what was going on and what was to happen. But he could suppose one thing.

Master Lloyd must know a lot more about Hell than other people.

Javier had the thought on his way to meet the King of Hell and saw Lloyd conversing with him. And right now, he could feel Master Lloyd knew something about Hell that no one else did.

But...

Whatever that was, he decided to trust his young master. At least he wasn’t the type of person to harm others. He held a history of devoting himself to the fiefdom and the people around him. So, Javier decided to trust him once more and dutifully followed his instructions.

“Do I have to dig according to the construction guideline?”

“Of course.”

Bzzt! In no time, the Construction Guideline was marked on the ground in detail. From that moment, Javier and Lloyd dug over and over again without ever getting exhausted. Javier’s dug with the power of a grandmaster. On top of the two, Ppodong and Hamang joined their efforts, so they were able to dig up a massive cave in only a few hours. Overall, the cave was shaped like a large gourd. The diameter of the opening was about

32 feet, and the slope of the passage that led from the opening was about 60 degrees in angle. At the end of the passage, which extended about 320 feet, sat a huge room. The depth, width, and height were 262, 656, and 164 feet, respectively. Lloyd then built a cozy tub at the center of the room and filled it up with the help of Hamang.

“Hamang! Hamamang!”

Slurp! As luck would have it, there was a boiling hot spring nearby, and Hamang gulped the hot spring as he blew on it as if he was drinking a cup of hot coffee. Then he carried the water from the hot spring into the tub. When it was done, Ggoming was next to take action.

“Ggoming,” called Lloyd.

“Ggoming?”

“Do you like taking baths?”

“Ggoming!”

“I see, you don’t like them very much.”

“Ggomiming!”

“Hmm, but you know what? I’ve been seeing fleas in your feathers lately.”

“Ggoming?”

“You should wash yourself, right?”

“G-ggoming!”

“Yes, good. Thank you for making a good choice. Time to dive in. ”

“Ggoming...!”

Splash! Ggoming jumped into the hot spring. At first, he seemed to loathe it, but when the water soaked his body, the muscles around his face relaxed

in ease.

“Ggo, Ggomiming...”

“Are you enjoying yourself?” asked Lloyd.

“Ggomiming...”

“Good, I’m glad. Since you like it so much, let’s leave you in there for around ten hours.”

“Ggoming...?”

“That’s how we can make a good stock.”

“...”

From then on, Ggoming stayed in the hot spring for ten consecutive hours. The water didn’t even get cold as the ground was full of heat. As a result, his prolonged stay in the water caused his feet to unreservedly swell. And soon, thanks to Ggoming’s sacrifice, the hot spring water turned into parrotbill stock.

“Ehem, that smells good.”

Lloyd carefully scooped the hot spring water, making sure that he didn’t spill a single drop. Then he sprayed it all around the entrance and passage of the cave. At last, Lloyd smiled with a glow of satisfaction, revealing all of his teeth.

“Whew, it’s done.”

A cave instead of a glass bottle trap. Parrotbill stock instead of chicken stock for bait. With that, everything was all set. He was ready to acquire a bulk of essential materials for the construction in one go. This special material that didn’t melt or bend under the lava was meant to stabilize and support the surface of the railway’s subbase and was used to build rails and ties on top of the layer at the same time. Now, the time had come to hunt

lava centipedes who would bring countless pissed-off demons to where he was.

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Chapter 234: Demons Must Be Abused (2)

Fwoooosh! Hiss! 200 legs rippled and whisked the lava, and the centipede went up to the ground and made its long body move forward.

Splash! A giant lava centipede came out of the lava lake. Its body was 98 feet long and about 3 feet wide. Truly, this centipede was a huge one, and its temper was extremely foul.

Swish! Hiss! It let out a deathly sound the moment it set foot on the ground, ready to bite and rip apart anything bothersome in sight with its huge jaw. However, contrary to the angry centipede, the demon on the centipede's back grinned in contentment.

Wahaha. This is what I'm talking about!

The one-horned demon flashed an evil smile, and a surge of conviction rose in its heart.

"A thick shell that can't be melted by the hottest lava! A jaw that can penetrate the sturdiest of armor! And the strength to crush a boulder in one stomp! We have gathered 30,000 creatures who possess all these features! Mwahaha!" the demon cried out triumphantly.

"Wahahahaha!" another joined in its cry.

"Die, Lloyd Frontera!"

"Let's end him, the master singer!"

"Hell's Singer? I will give you a taste of Hell!"

"Arghh!!"

At the one-horned demon's shout, the rest of the 30,000 demons followed suit, and 30,000 centipedes beneath them hissed. 30,000 demons and lava centipedes. They created a stately atmosphere as they charged forward. The

entire lava pond turned black as they marched, crushing and flattening the basalt boulders with their movements. All the creatures of Hell whose homes resided in their pathway hid themselves in fear.

It made sense. Demons were undoubtedly an unnerving force, but the lava centipedes were ghastly creatures, predators in the ecosystem of Hell. Their shell was so thick and hard that not even hot lava could melt it down. And their body reached from 65 to 98 feet in length. On top of everything, no creature in the lava pond could dare put up a fight against them due to their foul temper. Yet the demons had gathered up 30,000 of these horrifying predators. It wasn't an understatement to say they had brought with them the entire centipede population to Hell.

But I don't care!

The one-horned demon leading at the front of the march of 30,000 centipedes thought to itself.

He insulted us! How dare he insult us demons when he's just a human!

Its fist violently shivered at that thought. The demon felt a pang of shame. It had tried to nitpick the human and leave a dent in his reputation as the master singer. It had rushed to the edge of the Hell full of anticipation and dreams. But when it got there, the demon realized Lloyd had tricked all of them, asking why he must sing for the crowd. And he even acknowledged his hustling, bestowing a blessing for them to honor their parents instead of wasting their time with him.

That was more insulting!

Insulted. Humiliated. The mockery was something it could never forget. It wanted revenge. That was why it cooperated with the other demons and spent over 15 days rallying together all the lava centipedes in hell!

"What do we want?!" the one-horned demon roared.

"To humiliate Lloyd Frontera!"

“Or give him death!”

“Let’s end him!”

The one-horned demon cried out first, and 29,999 demons answered in unison. All the demons were convinced of one thing.

We’ll win this fight! No matter what!

After all, the legion of 30,000 lava centipedes was more than enough to take Lloyd down, even if he had that extremely powerful knight standing next to him.

Even Hell’s Knight, who commands the Corps in Hell, can only fight about 1,000 centipedes by itself!

That was the case for Giolexius, better known as Hell’s Knight, whom Lloyd and Javier defeated. Giolexius was the commander of the 1st Corps, which meant it was considerably stronger than the other knights in Hell. There was one time it faced 1300 lava centipedes by itself. That was its limit. Given that, 30,000 lava centipedes would easily destroy them, even if Lloyd Frontera sang an awful song and Javier Asrahan wielded his powerful sword.

Hahaha. Even if they had taken down Hell’s Knight, they’re still humans in the end. How strong could they possibly get during that short time? There will be no mercy for them. I’ll sit back and enjoy the show as those bugs beg for their lives!

Kaboom! At last, the 30,00 demons and lava centipedes arrived at the edge of Hell, and their eyes eagerly searched for the despicable human who caused them great humiliation. But...

“Where is he?”

Lloyd was missing from the scene. They scoured the area and searched for him in every direction around them. They even poked their heads into volcano craters, and yet, Lloyd Frontera was still nowhere to be found.

“Could it be that he ran away?” One of them postulated.

“No way!”

They were feeling flustered when...

Hiss? All of the lava centipedes flinched and shuddered in unison. Soon, they jerked their heads up and shook their antennas.

“Eh? What are they doing?”

The one-horned demon cocked its head. It considered the centipede’s behavior insignificant at first. But that turned out to be untrue. Gradually, the centipedes stopped listening. They began to ignore all of the demon’s orders and move on their own.

“Eh?! Eh?” The demon squealed.

It yelped at one of them to stop, but it was no use. In no time, the centipede dashed toward one direction with its antenna moving in alert, as though a tasty prey was waiting there. It aggressively charged forward in full force. *Swish! Swoosh!*

“Eek? Ack! What’s wrong with you?!”

The one-horned demon was flustered. But the situation didn’t end there. All the other centipedes nearby were the same, escaping the demon’s control and dashing toward a single place. The reason behind their sudden change was simple. A mouthwateringly appetizing scent was coming from this specific direction.

Hiss! Their antennas trembled in sheer excitement but didn’t know why. It was that smell. The scrumptious smell stimulated their instincts. It was like the smell of chicken stock! As soon as the scent enamored their noses, their whole body quivered. They yearned to soak themselves in this smell! Thus, they dashed in search of the slowly intensifying aroma, crossing a plain of volcanic ash and crushing any boulders in their way until they discovered a cave.

Hiss! They were certain. The rich aroma of stock was coming from a deep underground cave in this direction. The voices of the demons that were leading the centipedes fell on deaf ears.

“Hey! Stop! I said, stop! Hey!”

Hiss! They made for the cave right away, ignoring the demons’ yelling. As they crawled further down, their antennas became captivated by the aroma of stock that intensified the deeper they went in. In response, they ran forward in a frenzy. There was no way for them to stop. And finally, the moment they entered the innermost part of the cave, something came into view.

“Ggoming?”

It was a giant parrobill taking a bath, the bird’s feathers seemingly expanded from soaking in the water for several long hours. Besides the bird, there was a human who grinned as he scooped the hot bath water into a bucket.

“See? I told you they’d come.” The centipedes looked toward where the human directed his words, and they saw a silver-haired knight sitting down without a trace of surprise in his gaze. He was simply staring back at them with keen eyes like a butcher looking at a new slab of meat. Then they saw his hands move slowly. He was sharpening a sword on a whetstone.

Hiss...? The centipedes shuddered at the unexpected turn of events.

***

The hunt was a success. All 30,000 centipedes were taken care of, and every one of the 30,000 demons was captured. He used a very systematic process to make this happen.

Hiss? The moment the lava centipede at the very front flinched, Javier’s sword flashed in the air. With that, the centipede’s final fate was set in stone.

Slash! Scores of aura strands enveloped the bug's entire body, immediately cutting and dissecting its back, stomach, antenna, and legs in equal parts. The inside of the shell was chopped up into a smaller size that was easily transportable. This whole process took only an exact 0.2 seconds. By the time the rays of aura subsided, the lava centipede was neatly diced into pieces and ready to be put away. As for the one-horned demon on its back, Lloyd took care of it. He only needed to say one thing.

"Lower your stupid head."

"Yes, Master Lloyd."

Drop! Reading the room in a flash, the demon pelted to the corner and shoved its head against the ground, hands behind its back. It cried while consoling itself that at least the horn jutting from its forehead made it easier to find balance while its head was pressed into the ground. Meanwhile, the hunt continued.

Hiss?! When the next centipede entered the cave, drawn inside by the smell of parrotbill stock...

Slashh! Javier's aura flashed in the air without fail.

Thwop! The remaining demon dropped its head to the ground just like the first one. Meanwhile, Ppodong became busy with moving the centipede shells and soft tissue pieces expertly dismembered by Javier to ensure the cave would remain clean and the hunt would go on smoothly. He transferred the centipede remains to the exit opposite the entrance. And just like that, the hunt continued for the rest of the day. The demons outside tried to stop the centipedes when they figured out what was going on, but it was no use. Completely blinded by the intoxicating aroma of parrotbill stock, the bugs bolted right into Lloyd's trap without any care.

They entered the trap one after another, and Javier cut into them in consecutive order. Through this process, it took them a total of eight days to complete their hunt. All 30,000 centipedes were methodically dismembered into equal-sized pieces and put away. Their remains were stored in Lloyd's

makeshift supply warehouse. Every single one of the 30,000 demons was captured alive, and they all kneeled across the vast plain of volcanic ash.

“Mwhahahaha.”

“...”

“Hahaha. Mwhahahahaha.”

“...”

Lloyd’s eerie laughter filled the land. The demons swallowed dryly as they heard the ominous noise coming from him.

What’s going to happen to us now?

Everyone was filled with anxiety. It was understandable, considering the demons never imagined that the 30,000 lava centipedes they had ambitiously rallied would powerlessly get sliced into pieces. They didn’t foresee that Lloyd would set such a trap for them either. The fact that the silver-haired knight with him had risen above the status of a sword master was an even greater surprise to them. Not a single one of the demons ever thought they would be captured alive as they were currently.

Ha. My life as a demon. I should’ve led a trashier life.

The one-horned demon heaved a big sigh. It would’ve lived a more evil life had it known that this was how everything would end. It should have committed more wrongdoings without leaving behind any regrets instead of doing a half-assed job. But life was short and regret always came too late.

“Hey, you there,” called Lloyd.

Step. Lloyd approached the one-horned demon, and he looked down at it.

“I heard you incited all of these guys to move,” added Lloyd.

“...”

The one-horned demon kept its head low.

“So, isn’t it only right for you to be punished?” Lloyd spoke with a slightly raised voice.

“...”

Punish me or do whatever you want. You’re going to eventually kill me anyway. Why keep wasting your breath? The demon waited for its incoming death. But what Lloyd said afterward caught it by slight surprise.

“From now on, you won’t be able to die even if you want to. I’ll abuse you until you beg me to kill you instead.”

“Excuse me...?” the demon gasped and lifted its head in sheer confusion. Then it saw. It saw the smile of an evil employer who was hell-bent on abusing his workers in the most merciless and cruel way possible.

“Excuse me, my ass,” Lloyd huffed. “You’re going to work. I’m holding you captive right now.”

“...”

“So, you guys are my slaves from now on. Do you not understand what’s happening?”

“Um... then...”

“Yeah, ask your question,” allowed Lloyd.

“Are you not going to kill us?” the demon asked hopefully.

“Why would I kill you?” Lloyd tilted his head and beamed, wondering why on earth it was asking such a foolish question. “Don’t you agree that it’s a loss for me if I kill those I can abuse to near death?”

“...”

“So, why would I kill you? I can’t be bothered to, and it’s unnecessary.” Lloyd shook his head.

“...”

“If you have a death wish, then die from overwork. That’ll be the only way you can die from this moment onward.”

“...”

Kill me now instead, thought the one-horned demon as a shiver went down its shoulders. However, Lloyd’s smile was completely devoid of mercy, and correspondingly, there wasn’t an employment contract between them either.

I’m dealing with demons here.

Obviously, Lloyd wouldn’t be creating a contract. There also wouldn’t be any proper treatment or wages given to the workers. The reason was simple.

These guys are quite literally demons. If I treat them with kindness, they’ll take advantage of me. That’s the way of life in Hell.

Being kind caused more harm than good. Following the rules brought trouble to your door. Those were the rules of thumb in Hell. And since Lloyd was in Hell, he decided to do what demons do. He vowed to try his best to adhere to local customs this time around.

And my plan worked perfectly.

It wasn’t just a simple success. It was a grand success. Spreading a rumor through the King of Hell. Humiliating the demons after they gathered around him. Lloyd expected them to react poorly to his plan.

It’s just the nature of demons. They always pay back their grudges. And if the one that brought their wrath is someone superior to them, there’s no way they’d just let them off without a fight.

Lloyd predicted that they would pour all their efforts and resources into getting revenge. His prediction was on point. The demons rushed here with

the strongest creature they could control in Hell, the lava centipede.

The lava centipede made a short appearance in the novel.

As the name suggested, these centipedes lived in lava ponds. And so, their shells didn't melt in lavas. Not only that but since their shells were big and pleasing to look at, Lloyd believed they would become a key material in building the railroad tracks.

Moreover, there are 30,000 of them. This will be enough.

The foundation for the railroad. The railroad bed is on top of the foundation. And the railroad tie and rail that will be installed along the bed. Lloyd was able to obtain every material required to build those from the centipede. As luck would have it, he held plenty of experience when it came to catching centipedes. Where? In the military. How? By becoming a dutiful SCV of the administrative NCO.

Ha. Thinking about it pisses me off to this day.

At that time, the NCO was interested in healthy foods, and that could probably explain the two-week centipede hunt. He had to become a hunting specialist when the sergeant heard about the health benefits of drinking alcohol infused with centipedes.

I learned from that experience. Pour chicken stock into a plastic bottle, and just wait until the centipedes crawl into it. Then zap! Seriously, I was like a ginseng digger or a pest controller.

Anyway, thanks to his experience, Lloyd was able to successfully catch and kill lava centipedes and acquire 30,000 demon slaves. As he delved more into his accomplishment, the corners of his lips rose into an evil smirk.

"By the way, just to clarify, the stuff about safety first and whatnot? You can forget it. And obviously, there's no wage or additional stipend. Got it? If you have a problem, try breaking through Javier's watch and run away," Lloyd growled.

“…”

The one-horned demon and the others thought inwardly that this human was quite charming, in the sense that he was evil.

Ugh... I can’t fall for him... But he’s respectable!

Now, as Lloyd treated the demons, he was transformed into an unprecedentedly evil employer. And before he knew it, 30,000 demons were deeply impressed by his merciless attitude.

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Chapter 235: Demons Must Be Abused (3)

Hell strangely reminded Lloyd of Seoul. It was especially so now as Lloyd flew around the area on Ggoming's back.

Survey.

[Scanning will begin.]

Lloyd's gaze traveled down, and beneath the wide-spread Ggoming's wings, he saw the whole land span out.

"..."

Of course, Hell was different from Seoul. There were active volcanos erupting everywhere with pools of ketchup-like lava spilled out of their sides. The air surrounding him was full of heat. One glance around and the whole landscape didn't have any resemblance to the capital of Korea.

Yet, there is one similarity. It's that it's hard to breathe.

Volcanic ash flew everywhere in the air, reminding Lloyd of Seoul's fine dust. And the musty scent of sulfur reminded him of the gas from a car engine exhaust. But then, of course, this place was 30, 40, or possibly 50 times more deadly and pungent than Seoul.

But it's making me a bit nostalgic.

Lloyd wondered whether the woman in the first-floor gimbap restaurant in his room rental was doing well. Was the manager, who used to pick on him from time to time but took care of him, still struggling to pass the civil service examination?

Ah. Stop thinking about it.

Any further thoughts would just bring strange emotions to him. He wondered if he was starting to lose it as he was romanticizing this terrible

place with a twinge of nostalgia. Pulling himself together, Lloyd focused on surveying.

The terrain of the land isn't too rough to my relief, ignoring the lava.

He was currently surveying a plain here. The topography of Hell was surprisingly sleek. There weren't any excessively steep or jagged mountains. It was hard to find sharp cliffs and basins as well. Instead, the most common terrain was a flatland abundant with volcanic ash.

It must be due to all the volcanic activity.

There wasn't any time for the mountains to become taller. The volcanoes erupted and crumbled as soon as they showed signs of growing. The basins and valleys, even if they existed, were quickly filled with lava and volcanic ash. Because of these reasons, the overall terrain was flat. It seemed the construction would go fairly smoothly, thanks to it.

We don't have to dig any tunnels through mountains to lay the railroad or bridges over the valleys.

Just one straight railroad on the flatland. But what about hundreds of lava ponds intermittently spread throughout the whole place?

Just have to evade them with skill.

Just like that, Lloyd surveyed the flatland of Hell, never forgetting to look 16 feet underground as well. He meticulously studied the areas with relatively lesser volcanic ash and without lava influx. And he connected them in one route, which extended gradually from the edge of Hell to the Hell Castle, reaching 68 miles in total. And then he came back to the edge and arrived at the camp where he imprisoned the demon slaves.

Haah.

Lloyd hopped off Ggoming's back and shook his head. He had missed sleep for three days straight, having to tightly tense his eyes and focus on surveying with the help of the Asrahan Core Technique. Although he was

able to acquire the data for the entire route of the railroad, Lloyd felt a heavy weight of fatigue as if his eyes were soaked in cement.

“You are here,” said Javier when he saw Lloyd.

“I am here. Can I have some water?”

“Here it is.”

Lloyd gulped down the lukewarm hot spring water Javier held out. Just then, he became curious.

“Hey.”

“Yes.” Javier looked at Lloyd.

“I hope you didn’t desperately sit out here all day until I came back.”

“Please do not say such chilling words,” snapped Javier with a slight frown. “Of course, I did not.”

“Then how did you come out knowing I arrived?”

“I just felt it,” Javier replied.

“You felt it?” Lloyd arched his brow.

“Yes, since about five minutes ago.”

“Could you mean...”

“Yes, you are most likely right,” affirmed Javier. “I heard Sir Ggoming’s fluttering his wings.”

“...”

“That is how I realized you returned and thus came out to escort you.”

“...”

“Why are you not saying anything?” Javier’s gaze was fixed on Lloyd. He was confused.

“...”

“Master Lloyd?” Javier called.

“Yeah,” Lloyd blurted, blinking.

“What are you doing? You are staring at me without saying anything.”

“Oh, did you not hear my voice?”

“Excuse me?” Javier retorted.

“I was mumbling something very softly. I was badmouthing you.”

This time, it was Javier who didn’t respond.

“You didn’t hear what I said, right?”

“I do not wish to know what you said about me. However...”

“However what?” hurried Lloyd.

“At the very least, I know that those ill-spoken words contain your envy toward me.”

“What did you say?”

“I am taller than you,” stated Javier with a smug.

“...”

“And as for my face? There’s no comparison between us.”

“...”

“Swordsmanship, too.”

“...”

“Moreover, I am a better singer than you.”

“Wait!” Javier’s provocation invited Lloyd to stop him right there. “But I’ve never seen you sing before up to now.”

“No matter what, even if I lose my vocal cords or sing with my toenail, I am confident that I can sing better than you.”

“...”

And Javier smirked, looking straight into Lloyd’s eyes.

“...”

What is this feeling? Lloyd wondered. He felt like he just fired a plastic bullet, only to be shot back with an explosive cannonball. Lloyd shook off this growing feeling of shame with a wry laugh.

“Well, anyway, how were the demons while I was gone?” Lloyd asked, regaining composure.

“They were relatively well-mannered.”

“Really?” That was a surprise, Lloyd thought as he chuckled. “I expected them to come up with all sorts of tricks and schemes to get out of here.”

“Of course,” affirmed Javier, “they tried the very first day you left to survey.”

“They did?”

“Yes, there was one that tried to sneak out of the camp, and another attempted to raise a riot by stirring up the other demons.”

“So?” Lloyd asked. “Were you able to suppress them all?”

“Yes.”

“You didn’t kill them, did you?”

“No. However...” A faint smile spread across Javier’s face. “I had a little fun with them.”

“You had fun with them?” Lloyd lifted his brows.

“Yes, I had been curious about what style of swordsmanship was popular in Hell.”

“...”

“I was very curious, but not anymore.”

“...”

What a terrifying and dreadful bastard. Lloyd inwardly paid tribute to the demons who became Javier’s training partners and were endlessly abused.

“Good job,” Lloyd sincerely encouraged Javier, “Keep abusing them.”

“Are you serious?”

“Of course I am. Set the order right when you have the chance.”

Javier seemed pleased to hear that. “For how long should I do it?”

“Until I am done with designing, and we start the construction.”

“Understood.”

From that day onward, Lloyd busied himself with designing while Javier focused on abusing the demons. As days progressed, the planning sheet for design became jam-packed with construction plans. And the demons were put to intense training at Javier’s command. This prompted the demons to make an earnest prayer in their hearts.

Ha... Ha! Whew! Ha... Please finish the construction design or whatever it is faster!

At Javier’s command, they rolled forward. And rolled backward. When they moved the wrong way, they were forced into a fierce one-on-one sword fight with the grandmaster.

And so, Lloyd gradually completed his design as the demons sweated buckets from their raid training. He then drew up an overall track plan and conducted a field survey following what he wrote. After drawing the track plan on a 1/50,000 scale, he worked on the cross-section plan after cutting the track every 164 feet. Lastly, he conducted the conclusion survey, and the final process, and then drew another track plan. This time, it was 1/1,000 in scale. That was the basic design process, and it was comparatively simple as the train wouldn’t stop at any station.

I’m done.

After organizing the cross-sectional track plan in 65 feet intervals, he smiled contently. The design was finally finished, but it wasn’t the time to celebrate. With the completed plan, it was time to jumpstart the construction. So, Lloyd knuckled down with the railroad construction, and his evil instinct as an employer shined out of him.

“Over there! Group 11! I can see your shovel! Group 13! Didn’t I tell you to dig up a new lava path before the day is over?! Group 14! Why are you taking a break when I never permitted you one?”

This construction project involved building a roadbed at the edge of Hell. A roadbed was a sort of passage that was built for railroads to be laid out on. It was a common sight to see trains traveling on slightly elevated ground instead of ordinary land. That was a roadbed, to put it simply.

Roadbeds are important. They serve as the basis for all railroads and should be well-built. That way, a railroad can stay stable and won’t get waterlogged or sink down.

Lloyd chose to use sand piles for most of the roadbeds. It was an inevitable choice given the lava-filled environment of Hell.

It’s an obvious choice. There’s no way to know when the lava will overflow.

Of course, the centipede shells that would be used for the railroad didn’t melt. But as for the ground underneath, that was another problem.

To give a description, this area is similar to a swamp. The difference is the flowing lava in the ground, which is much stickier than water.

What would happen if the lava flowed over the railroad? It could lose a rail or tie from the lateral pressure as a result. Even if that didn’t happen by pure luck, the lava covering the railroad could also become a problem by solidifying. In any case, an uncontrolled lava flow would wreak havoc and halt the train operation.

So, the roadbed has to be sufficiently elevated.

Lloyd elevated the bed as high as he could to ensure that it would prevent most flows of lava from reaching the railroad. To his relief, Lloyd had plenty of material to build the bed. The volcanic ash was piled all around the area.

“Hey! I can see your shovels! What did I tell you about flattening volcanic ash with your shovels?” bawled Lloyd.

“Spray on the hot spring water until it gets sticky. Then tap down!”

The demons in the construction site yelled in unison.

“You told us to tap as fast as we can until our shovels turn into a blur!”

“Yes, that’s right!” Lloyd cried out. “I told you. Tap! Tap!”

“Yes!”

“Then why am I seeing shovels?”

The demons didn’t know what to say to that.

“Tap until your shovels can’t be seen!” screamed Lloyd. “Tap until your eyelashes and nose hairs sway! Tap down until your shoulders fall off!”

“Yes, Master!” The demons yelled. Everyone was on the verge of collapsing from exhaustion. But Lloyd didn’t give any mercy to them. No, the more tired they became, Lloyd pushed them to work even harder. Of course, they didn’t get to get off work either.

Huff, huff! “H-help me...”

“Argh... I am thirsty... I want a glass of strawberry lava juice...”

“Uh... When did we start working?”

“About ten days ago, I think...”

“And we never took a single break? Is this for real?”

“It’s real... I think...”

“Just kill us now.”

“Eh, die alone, leave me out of it...”

“What did you say?”

The demons, at times, lamented their own misfortune. Otherwise, they let off steam by lashing out at each other. But all of them worked diligently, following Lloyd's instructions without any complaint. Why?

“Whew, but you know that human, Lloyd Frontera. I feel a bit drawn to him the more time I spend experiencing his evilness.”

“What?” a demon gasped. “Are you nuts?”

“Come on. That’s the truth. Who would have known he’d work us so hard like this?”

“Well, that’s true, but-”

“Hey, that’s why you’re not even trying to run away.”

“Hey!” the accused demon shouted defensively. “I tried once and almost got killed!”

“So what? It’s not like you to stop after just one near-death escape.”

“...”

“See? You do have a good impression of him.”

“What do you mean? I made a good impression? On him?”

“Yeah.”

“What impression?”

Lloyd’s fan arched his brows. “You want to learn his evil and sly ways of life. Like I do.”

“...”

“Ha... To be honest, I don’t want to do this. Dammit, I’m a demon for Pete’s sake. I hate admiring a human’s evilness and pettiness and wanting to learn from him. But…” The grumbling demon heaved a sigh, “I still have to learn. A great demon is always prepared to learn.”

“Wow, that was a long excuse,” accused its comrade.

“You can say I’m making an excuse, but I don’t care. As long as I can become a demon that properly dishonors their parents.”

“...”

“Eh, what’s the point of this conversation? Let’s shovel now. Whew! Crap!”

“You’re right. Crap!”

Similarly, most demons knew in their hearts that Lloyd was prettier, slyer, eviler, and more stubborn than themselves. And so, they all decided to learn from this opportunity and stay by Lloyd’s side doing construction work for

as long as possible. They would observe, study, reflect on, and copy his actions to become a more wicked demon. Their hearts burned with the desire to develop themselves and gave all to their shoveling.

“Hey!” shouted Lloyd. “Stop chatting and use that energy to shovel!”

Encouraged by Lloyd’s merciless nagging and frightened by Javier’s watch, they constructed roadbeds one section after another. About three months later, a sturdy 68-mile-long bed was built from the edge of Hell. The number of slopes and curves was kept minimal. Each car wasn’t meant to travel on more than three elevated slopes, and each slope was to be less than 1.8 miles long. Everything was designed in accordance with Lloyd’s careful and deliberate plan.

Good.

In no time, the 68-mile roadbed started to show its final outline. Lloyd clenched his fists as he looked down at it from the sky. The construction was going better than he expected. It was all thanks to the hard work of 30,000 demons, all of whom almost never slacked off. Interestingly, these demons were more cooperative when he treated them harshly and without any show of mercy.

Perverts.

Lloyd landed Ggoming, smiling wryly. His smile widened with a streak of greater satisfaction when he knuckled down to inspect the bed constructed today.

It’s flawless.

It was near perfection, precisely meeting all of his size and durability requirements.

The project will hopefully continue as it is now. Once the bed is completed, it’ll be time to build the tracks.

Then the construction would be over. Next, he would simply inform the King of Hell how to maintain and operate the railroad before receiving his payment. With that, he'd finally be able to liberate the soul of Anticus.

Then I'll be able to obtain Dragon King Verkis's support.

A lifetime warranty for the Bone Dragon. A promise of endless treasure. Even one extra life on top of everything. It all culminated to create the perfect conditions for him to enjoy and experience the best of life.

So, let's work harder to end the construction in a success.

Calming his pounding heart, Lloyd rounded off the bed inspection. And in his excitement, he didn't see the desolate-looking ghost wandering near the flatland—where Hell's first railroad was being constructed—as it looked at Lloyd in sheer panic.

What the heck? That's... me?!

The lost ghost. The former hooligan of the Frontera barony. The man whose body was suddenly stolen without warning one day. The dead soul who became a resident in Hell. The ghost of Lloyd Frontera's eyes snapped open when he looked at Lloyd.

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Chapter 236: The Pleading Hooligan (1)

Lloyd Frontera, the hooligan, was a mess. His personality. Behavior. Attitude. Not a single attribute of his was worthy of praise. He destroyed himself and those around him, slacking off and behaving recklessly at any given chance. He was always preoccupied with his thoughts about the Frontera fiefdom, a boring and hideous province. He pitied his fate of being born and rotting away in such a place. And so, he was always angry. He was enraged by the lack of his family's status and his unfulfilled greed. The anger, disappointment, and frustration inside the young master were taken out on everyone around him. He hurled insults at maids and physically assaulted servants. He mistreated his parents and the rest of the family.

And he drank. Getting intoxicated made him feel good. It was the only source of consolation in his life. So, the young master kept drinking more. That day was no different. He drank himself into a stupor at the pub. As he continued drinking, he felt a shaft of rage.

What happened after was unclear. Did he destroy everything? He vaguely recalled toppling over, throwing around, and stomping on the tables, chairs, and everything else he could lay his eyes on. The pub owner seemed to have teared up, choking in his tears to please stop while he was at it. But he must have wrenched the man off. How that man shuddered and flinched in fear when Lloyd tossed a glare and lifted his fist high! How entertaining the sight of that useless man was! Just like that, as Lloyd walked back home, he giggled as the scene replayed in his head. And then, when he got home, he flung himself into bed and fell asleep. That was his last memory. The last memory he had inside his physical body.

And afterward... That bastard...

The ghost of Hooligan Lloyd blinked, his eyes shaking. And he tossed his vacant gaze to the sky, where his flesh was. He couldn't forget the morning of that day. How could he forget? The moment he became the ghost against his will? The moment when the very bastard that stole his body woke up and got out of bed?

...

On that very morning, the bastard skillfully struck up a conversation with Javier like everything was normal. As if it wasn’t enough to steal his body, the man even pretended to be him. The sight flipped his lid. No, actually, Ghost Lloyd was scared. Flustered and afraid. The young master couldn’t wrap his head around why his body was stolen and he became a ghost. There was nothing he could understand or do about it.

Yes. He was powerless. But he wanted to get his body back. So, he stuck next to the thief 24/7, never leaving his side as the thief slept, ate, and whatnot. Ghost Lloyd resorted to every attempt to get his body back. He yearned to drive away the fraud who was pretending to be him and restore his possession. But it was impossible. All his attempts failed. It was a fruitless endeavor even when the fraud passed out after defeating the Gigatitan in Cremo and waking up to reunite with his parents.

...

Ghost Lloyd was certain that he’d succeed when the fraud was in an unconscious, vegetative state. But even then, it was a failure. Not enough with that, he had to watch the fraud hug his parents who had run up to him in tears. He despaired seeing their concerned expression and eyes full of worry for the fraud’s wellbeing as their fingers trembled.

...

He felt dismayed, hopeless, defeated... and regretful for his crooked ways of life. That was when Ghost Lloyd realized. There was no excuse for him. Throughout the year, he glued himself to the thief of his body, and Ghost Lloyd saw how the latter worked. How earnest and desperate the man was. How purposeful his actions were. Ghost Lloyd was able to observe him for longer and more closely than anyone else. And so, he couldn’t make an excuse even when he wanted to.

I... lived blaming everything on my poor family status.

But he was different. The man possessed the same body as him, along with his family's low status and crippling debt. But he acted like it was nothing and even as if he had gotten lucky with these conditions. He desperately worked hard to make money, so much so that Ghost Lloyd wondered if such an endeavor was possible for a human. Sometimes, the fraud put himself in harm's way, changing the reputation Ghost Lloyd had tanked to the bottom by being a wretched hooligan.

Ghost Lloyd knew that all of these accomplishments would be unimaginable for him. He couldn't give out any excuse because he saw it with his own eyes. So, he accepted defeat. As he saw his parents hug the fake Lloyd in tears, he thought to himself that it was all for the better, that his body was stolen, and that there was nothing else he could do. And just like that, he left and came to the underworld, mixing in with the dead. Then he fell to Hell and went to the Hell Castle, only to be kicked out without receiving a sentence. The reason was simple.

I'm neither dead nor living.

His body was still alive, although taken away, so he wasn't dead. However, he wasn't alive either, as he didn't possess a living body. In other words, he was a spiritual refugee, a ghost without a home country. A buoying ghost that was neither living nor dead. A ghost that didn't belong to any world. That was what he was. And so, from then on, he lived and spent his time in the corner of Hell since that was the only way. He was scared of demons, as his soul would be exterminated if they got to him. So, Ghost Lloyd lived in apprehension, fearing that he might be seen by demons.

For how long? There was no way of knowing. Hell didn't have changing seasons. Thus, he simply hid every day to survive, bearing every moment in Hell. But he didn't have many regrets as he regarded his current life as a fitting punishment for his crooked ways in the past. But now? For the first time, he regretted the decision to come down to Hell as he saw fake Lloyd standing in front of his eyes.

I gave up my body to him. Yet, that idiot already died and came here?!

This place was Hell, and Ghost Lloyd saw his thief here! Too soon!

That scumbag!

Ghost Lloyd teared up, a sudden onrush of regret washing through him. He shouldn't have given up his body too soon. Eventually, his patience snapped.

"Hey!" shouted Ghost Lloyd and rushed toward Lloyd. *"Since you're already dead, it's time to die in my hands now, you scumbag!"*

Ghost Lloyd ran up to Lloyd and threw a punch. Lloyd felt flustered.

"What is this...?" Lloyd was inspecting the roadbed, and when a dead soul appeared out of nowhere and wielded a fist, he wondered if it had lost its mind.

How dare a mere dead soul attack me when even demons cower in my presence?

Swish. Lloyd easily shifted his feet. Normally, he just chose to avoid fighting. But he, too, was on the verge of being a high-level sword expert, which meant that he could easily dodge the fist of a dead soul. Launching a counterattack was easy for him as well.

Thwack! Lloyd stretched out his hand after avoiding the attack.

Slap! Slap! Slap!

Lloyd slapped the dead soul, whose face jerked to the side along with a sharp sound. But that wasn't the end of his attack.

Thwack! When the dead reeled, Lloyd used his shoulder to push the former's back as he hugged its knees. And he pulled, letting his weight pin on the dead.

"Eh?! Eh?"

When Ghost Lloyd fell to the ground, Lloyd immediately worked to push the ghost's stomach with his right knee while his left leg and his right hand

pressed down on both of its legs. And with his left hand, he clenched its throat. Hooligan Lloyd was completely suppressed.

Woah. What is this now?

Lloyd let out a snort after suppressing Ghost Lloyd without breaking a sweat, wondering if it was a resident in Hell that was against the indiscriminate development of the railroad. Did he need to act as an evil corporate developer again? Lloyd entertained this silly thought for a while before getting a proper look at the dead soul's face. But when he checked its face properly, he flinched.

"Hmm?" Lloyd gasped and added, "Lloyd. Frontera?"

"Did you finally notice me, you bastard?"

"..."

It was really Lloyd Frontera. Though he was having trouble accepting the sudden turn of events, the dead soul glowering at him as it flailed under his weight was the hooligan, Lloyd Frontera. His face had somewhat faded away and even became half-transparent. However, the living Lloyd instantly recognized by instinct who it was.

What is happening? How am I supposed to react to this?

For a second, Lloyd was completely thrown off balance. Meeting the hooligan Lloyd Frontera was the very last thing he expected to happen. He wasn't merely surprised. Lloyd felt as if he was caught red-handed in a crime. It was understandable considering that he was meeting the very person he unintentionally stole his body from. The ghost was the source of guilt for Lloyd. But soon enough, he pulled himself together. There was no need to be flustered. First, he had to figure out what was going on. He collected his thoughts and fixed his expression before speaking.

"Why are you here?" blurted Lloyd.

"That's my question, you bastard," Ghost Lloyd shot back.

Of course. The Ghost Lloyd didn’t give a kind response. Instead, its gaze turned hostile.

“How did you die and come here so early?”

“Me?” asked Lloyd with a frown. “Are you asking if I’m dead?”

“Yes.”

“I’m not dead at all.”

That was when it struck him that Ghost Lloyd had misunderstood what happened.

“I’m not dead,” blurted Lloyd.

“What?”

“I said I’m not dead.”

“Cut the bullcrap. Then why are you here in Hell if you aren’t dead?!”

“I was asked by a dragon to come here, and I’m building something for the King of Hell. I’m working here,” said Lloyd matter-of-factly.

“Eh...?”

“Yes. Consider it a business trip.”

“...”

Confusion rushed through Ghost Lloyd. Asked by a dragon? Building something for the King of Hell? A silly question came out of its mouth against its will.

“You. What in the world have you been doing with my body?”

“Nothing much. Just been trying to live diligently.”

“...”

“Then why are you here?” asked Lloyd this time.

“What do you mean, why?” snapped Ghost Lloyd. *“It’s because of you! I was living an ordinary life until you did this to me! Got it?”* His nostrils flared.

From then on, Ghost Lloyd screeched and screamed, sharing the story beginning from the day its body was taken away. It complained, protested, and shouted. It mourned its berating life in anger, pleading, and begging.

“So please... help me. Come on! I don’t want to be here. I’m sick of being neither dead nor living. Please... Get me revived or something!”

“...”

“It’s because of you. I’m neither dead nor living because you took away my body. So why should you be the only one living a good life? Come on! What did I do wrong?”

“...”

“Take responsibility for what you did! Do something for me!”

“Whew...”

Lloyd heaved a sigh he had been holding in. Hooligan Lloyd was still pinned to the ground, and Lloyd slightly pitied the guy after he heard the former’s story.

He’s become a soul that’s neither dead nor living.

So, Ghost Lloyd didn’t belong either in the outside world or the underworld. Living Lloyd never knew that it’d be roaming around in such a state.

It’s in a completely stateless condition.

Lloyd grasped the current situation after organizing his thoughts. He was flustered. Sure, he pitied Hooligan Lloyd and felt bad for it. But...

“How am I supposed to help you? Do you have any ideas?” Lloyd’s voice was now soft.

“That’s for you to find out!” shrieked Ghost Lloyd.

“...”

“That’s what my servants and maids did for me at home! I didn’t have to say it out loud. They all worked and did things for me! Don’t you think that’s the obvious thing to do?!”

“No, it’s not.”

Another sigh came out of Lloyd’s mouth. Sure, he sorely felt bad for Hooligan Lloyd, but he figured that the latter hadn’t gotten rid of its foul nature.

“First, listen to me carefully.”

Lloyd looked straight into Hooligan Lloyd’s eyes.

“First of all, you are asking me for a favor. So, don’t shout or throw a tantrum. You are not a baby.”

“...”

“Two. Let’s decide our nicknames.”

“What?”

“Nicknames. Don’t you know what that is?”

“I know, of course. But why should I do that? I’m Lloyd. You’re a fake,” Hooligan Lloyd protested.

“But I’m Lloyd, too.”

“Bullcrap! You’re nothing but a fake.”

“Then do you plan on keeping calling me a fake?”

“Of course.”

“Then I won’t help you.” Lloyd shook his head resolutely.

“What?”

“It’s offensive.”

“...”

Hooligan Lloyd swallowed, and that was when it hit Ghost Lloyd.

Right. I forgot he was a spiteful and petty bastard.

That was what Ghost Lloyd had observed from watching this fake for almost a year. And after having a conversation with him, it could even more clearly sense how petty the other was. Forcefully hiding the dismay in its voice, it asked, *“T-then what are you saying we should do?”*

“Let’s do rock scissors paper. The winner will be called Lloyd. The loser is Frontera. How’s that?”

“That doesn’t make any-”

“Rock...” put in Lloyd.

“Hey, you out of your mind?”

“If you don’t play, you lose. Paper, scissors...”

“Oh, come on!”

“Shoot!”

Swoosh! Two Lloyds held out their hands. Lloyd chose scissors. Hooligan Lloyd chose paper. A satisfied smile played across the former's face.

"Great. Since I won, I'll be called Lloyd."

"Wow. This is nuts. It wasn't enough with my body; you're stealing my name too?"

"At least I'm calling you by your last name, Frontera."

"Dammit. Then let me go now," muttered Frontera. Lloyd's gaze turned wistful as he watched Frontera.

Haah. I feel quite sorry for him.

It wasn't on purpose that he took this man's body. He never intended to in the first place. The event was a mere accident. But it was undeniably true that the unintended incident had completely changed his and the hooligan's destinies.

I've been on a winning streak while this bastard turned into a ghost. Tsk.

Though nothing was by design, Lloyd still felt apologetic. But, of course, it wasn't just 100% guilt. There were things that he thought he should be credited for.

The thing is, had I not taken away his body... He'd have died in the corner of a pub about 15 months after...

That was the destiny Lloyd Frontera met in the novel, something that would have happened without a doubt if his body was not taken away. But it wasn't only Lloyd who was slated to meet a tragic death.

The baron, baroness, and Julian too.

The entire family was set to either kill themselves or get killed. That would have happened had it not been for himself. And so, technically speaking, he was a savior to the family of Lloyd Frontera.

Haah. I kind of want to call it even.

That was Lloyd's honest thought. He wondered if it was necessary to help out this hooligan. Despite that, he was bothered. A part of him was pricked with guilt and so was his conscience. So, Lloyd felt that he couldn't just ignore the issue, particularly when he thought of the count and countess, who were always kind to him.

I pretended to be their son all along. So, if I overlook the trouble their real son is facing and turn a blind eye, then I'd be doing an injustice to them.

When his thoughts reached there, he was able to make a decision.

"Hey, Frontera," Lloyd called, "Listen carefully. I get what you're going through and what you want. But right now, I'm not in the place to help you right away."

"What? You scumbag, I'm going-"

"Stop cursing," Lloyd put in, "and listen to me until I finish. I'm swamped with work right now. The construction for the King of Hell is in full swing. So, let me just wrap up what I'm doing first. Neither of us knows how I can help you anyway." Lloyd looked at Frontera meaningfully.

"You are right, but..."

"That's why I'll try to search for ways to help you while I'm finishing the construction. Okay? So, get in my inner pocket and stay quiet."

"In your inner pocket?" Frontera asked in confusion.

"Yeah." Lloyd chuckled. "You can become smaller since you're a ghost, right?"

"I could if you let me go."

"So, shrink yourself and stay in my pocket for the time being."

"Why should I do that?"

“I’m giving you the chance to be safe until I’m done with this construction. Or what, do you want the demons to get you and be exterminated?”

“…”

“You now get why I’m making this suggestion?”

“Haah. Dammit.” I get it. So let this go first,” grumbled Frontera.

Lloyd freed Frontera, who downsized his own form. Lloyd introduced Frontera to his friends in his inner pocket.

“Hey, Ppodong. Bangul. Hamang. Ggoming. This is Frontera. Don’t hit or pester him. But be nice, okay?”

“Ppo? Bang? Ha? Ggo?”

Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, and Ggoming were enjoying a nap in Lloyd’s inner pocket. The four fantastical creatures widened their eyes at the sight of Frontera, who largely possessed the same appearance as Lloyd. The ghost sparked their curiosity. What about Frontera? He was flabbergasted.

“Ack!!! What are these fur balls?!” yelped Frontera.

“Well, they’re your friends for now. You said you stuck by me for a year or so. Then you should have seen all of them except maybe Ggoming,” drawled Lloyd.

“Hey!” shouted Ghost Lloyd. *“What does that have to do with anything? Why do I have to be with these things!”*

“Don’t like it? What, you want me to chuck you to the demons then?”

“…”

“That’s worse, right?”

“…”

“Then be nice and get along. Don’t make them hate you for no reason.”

Lloyd then smiled in a meaningful way because it looked like they were already disliking Frontera. The four of them were glowering at Frontera for calling them “these things” a while ago. But Lloyd paid no attention to it.

“Okay, time to go in.”

“H-hold on!”

“Closing the button now.”

“Hey!” Boing! Lloyd shoved Frontera into his inner pocket and closed the button. Later, he heard a ruffling noise coming from his pocket. It looked like the four of them were very friendly.

Haah. I bought some time for now.

Lloyd sighed at length. To be honest, he didn’t have any idea how he could help out the ghost.

But at least I didn’t make any promises. I just said I’d search for ways I could help.

That was his escape. In case he fails to give any help, he can always say, “I tried, but I couldn’t find ways to help you out.”

And for the time being, it’s better to keep him hidden. That way, Javier won’t find out about him.

Javier didn’t have any suspicions about Lloyd’s identity. So, what would happen if he saw the ghost of Lloyd Frontera, the real one? What if he learns the truth? Lloyd couldn’t imagine what his reaction would be. As such, he decided it would be best to keep Frontera hidden for now. Right then...

“Master Lloyd? Why are you sighing so heavily?”

Right when he thought so, Javier’s voice came close behind him without any warning. It happened much too unexpectedly for Lloyd. His heart jumped out of his chest at Javier’s sudden question.

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Chapter 237: The Pleading Hooligan (2)

“Master Lloyd? Why are you sighing so heavily?”

The sound of Javier’s voice came much too abruptly, catching Lloyd by sheer surprise.

“...!”

Was this what people meant when they said their hearts jumped out of their chests? Lloyd flinched but tried hard not to show it. He bit his lips involuntarily, held his breath for a moment while darting his eyes, and racked his brain for something to say. Then he turned around, thinking about how relieving it was that Javier didn’t see his expression as he approached him from behind. Lloyd chuckled.

“How can I not?” Lloyd grumbled as he pointed to the roadbed construction site. “Do you see that? The roadbed there? It’s driving me up the wall, really.”

“Is there something wrong?”

“Yes, there is. The upper part of the bed. It’s a big mess. Seriously, I warned them so many times not to build it like that. Those demons never listen,” sighed Lloyd, shaking his head.

Javier observed the area. “Hmm, it looks fine to me.”

“I see a lot of problems even if it looks fine to you. If the bed and rail are left in this state, everything’s going to completely warp later on.”

“Is that so?”

“Yeah, I should call the demons and fix it up again. For Pete’s sake. I can’t trust them with anything like this.”

“You must miss Sir Bayern,” Javier said.

“Mhm, I do, along with the Engineering and Skeleton Corps as well.”

Lloyd’s smile turned rueful. Even though he brought up the topic to change the conversation, he did miss Sir Bayern and the Engineering and Skeleton Corps in his fiefdom. After all, he had undergone countless construction projects with them. They were seasoned, experienced workers whom Lloyd could trust to do quality work.

“But what are you doing here?” finally asked Lloyd.

“I think it is time for you to eat.”

“Please tell me that we’re not having grilled lava centipede belly for dinner again.”

“Unfortunately, that is on our menu for tonight as well.”

“Is that really our best option?” asked Lloyd accusingly.

“Indeed. It is the only meal we can cook with what is available here.”

“But,” reasoned Lloyd, “what about steaming it? Or frying it even?”

“There isn’t enough water to cook with steam, and there is no flour to coat the meat.”

“Then what about eating it raw?”

“Eating it raw?” Javier frowned.

“Yeah, like soy sauce marinated raw crabs... Anyway, I mean just raw.”

“Do you truly want to eat it raw?”

“No...”

Lloyd let out a sigh. Three months had passed since the construction took off. And all this time, he had eaten a sickening amount of centipede meat. It

was virtually the only food they had in this place. The meat was quite juicy at first, but the mere smell of it made his stomach turn now.

“Still, nothing can be done about it. Let’s go.”

Lloyd started to walk while letting out another big sigh. He moved one step ahead of Javier. A faint smile appeared on his face unbeknownst to the knight, and his heart felt lighter.

Whew. That went well.

It was a challenge, but he managed to change the subject of their conversation. By the looks of it, it didn’t seem like Javier noticed anything.

It’d have been a serious headache if Javier caught me.

Lloyd stroked his chest, feeling the bulge of his inner pocket. Hooligan Frontera’s ghost was there. Lloyd’s heart had jumped out of his chest, fearing that Javier had heard their scuffle. But as he changed their conversation topic and quietly observed, Javier seemed to not have seen anything. This realization, at last, calmed his heart which was pounding in panic. His steps grew slightly lighter, whereas Javier’s gaze grew heavier.

There’s something strange about Master Lloyd.

Javier knew his young master wasn’t the type to grumble over food. At least, he wasn’t after giving up his hooligan ways. He never refused food, even when the given offer was plain or unpleasant. The man wasn’t picky when it came to food, nor did he get sick of anything. Even if he was served the same dish for ten consecutive days, or even a month straight, he still ate without a word of complaint. Perhaps he had some complaints, but his young master never voiced them out loud. The man ate like he had been starved for years and seemed to fully understand the preciousness of food. But just now...

He blatantly said that he was tired of eating centipede meat.

The man was without complaint in the morning but suddenly threw a fit over their repetitive meals during dinner. It was only natural that Javier regarded his behavior as strange.

Moreover, the way he was talking to himself earlier was definitely strange.

Javier shot a meaningful gaze toward Lloyd, who was walking ahead of him. Though he didn't say anything, he had heard Lloyd talk to himself right before he approached him.

It was like he was murmuring to himself. No, it seemed as though there were two Master Lloyds conversing with each other.

It was hard to believe, but he did feel that way. The din that came from the nearby volcano deafened his hearing, so he couldn't catch the details. But Javier caught on to the tone and atmosphere of the conversation.

It felt like Master Lloyd was talking with another Master Lloyd. What is stranger is that… I heard two different tones of voice in the conversation.

Lloyd's self-talk sounded more like two people conversing or even quarreling with each other in the same voice.

Not only that, one of the two sounded... much like the old Master Lloyd.

It really did. One was using the very tone his young master used as a hooligan before he started leading a proper life. In other words, the chatter Javier accidentally overheard sounded like a quarrel between Master Lloyd of the present and the past.

"..."

Javier considered if Master Lloyd was bipolar.

No. It doesn't seem that way.

Javier softly shook his head. There weren't any signs in Lloyd that indicated such. This made Javier feel more confused.

Furthermore, the King of Hell addressed him with a strange name. Suho Kim. What could that mean?

Lloyd had retorted that he knew nothing about it. But Javier begged to differ.

Master Lloyd seems to know something.

But whatever that was, it looked like his young master wasn't revealing it. The longer he stayed by the latter's side, the feeling just grew stronger.

Right. From long ago, there was always more than one strange thing about him.

To be exact, it was a few years ago when he changed, that is, around the time he suddenly undertook the construction of ondol. That truly marked the change in him. A completely different person. At that time, Javier regarded the change to be mysterious but not so bad. After all, the hopeless hooligan had become dutiful and hardworking in one day. Everyone, including Javier, welcomed the change in Lloyd. But what about now? Javier felt a mild pang of nervousness over the possibility that he'd go back to his old hooligan ways. The man had a record of a complete change, so there wasn't any guarantee that he wouldn't change again. Javier was more nervous because of that.

Master Lloyd, I wish to protect the current hardworking version of you.

Though Javier nitpicked Lloyd for being a petty and sneaky person, the former thought that the present Lloyd was incomparably better than the hooligan Lloyd from before. Deep down in his heart, Javier knew that he could sincerely trust and follow his young master. That made him all the more anxious.

What should I do... if Master Lloyd goes back to his old ways?

Javier had no idea. He could only pray that such a thing would never happen and bring misfortune to everyone. With that thought, he simply made a resolve.

I do not know how I can help out, but I will do everything to protect your current self.

Javier's eyes held a glint of firm determination as they gazed at Lloyd, who was walking ahead of him.

***

The railroad construction continued, so there wasn't any immediate way to seek ways to help out Hooligan Frontera. And so, Lloyd focused on the construction at hand, the 68-mile railroad bed from the edge of Hell to the Hell Castle entering the last phase. During the construction, Lloyd abused and exploited 30,000 demons in a more efficient manner. The secret was simple. He needed to do his best to act as an evil developer.

"Everyone already expected this, right? Get ready to pull an all-nighter!"

A bonus stipend for working overnight? There was obviously none. What about welfare benefits for working in a poor environment? That was non-existent as well. Lloyd maliciously exploited the others to no end, never letting them get off work. And when it seemed like their productivity went down, Lloyd summoned everyone and lashed out at them, grilling them to do better.

"Okay," shouted Lloyd, "Repeat after me! I am tired and slow because I lack passion and tenacity!"

"Passion! Tenacity!"

"Speak louder!" boomed Lloyd.

"PASSIOOON! TENACITYYY!"

"Okay! Work harder with that energy!" proclaimed Lloyd with a glow of satisfaction

"Eek...!" one of the demons cried out. "But it's too hard and tiring!"

"Shut up! Demons are supposed to be in pain and tired!"

Of course, all of this went without saying that it stood entirely opposite to Lloyd's usual philosophy. Hard work was to be met with fair compensation. Dangerous tasks were to be guided with safety measures and hazard pay. And everything was to be included in the labor contract. This was all that Lloyd normally believed because he hoped that none of his awful experiences on construction sites in the past would happen in his own field. He didn't want there to be any sorrow, mortification, or extortion of wages for his workers. But right now, the situation was completely different.

I'm in Hell!

Hell turned out to be a fanciful place. Had he treated the human workers in the same fashion he treated the demons, the entire construction site would have been flipped upside down, and a massive ruckus would have occurred. But this place was poles apart. The harsher he treated the demons, the more they enjoyed it! The greater the burden on their shoulders, the happier they became! The more Lloyd disregarded their welfare and whatnot, the closer they floated to cloud nine!

They seem like perverted nutcases. It's almost disturbing at this point.

The demons reacted in such a way that the thought just came naturally. So, in short, demons in this world thought lowly of the others who treated them in a meek and reasonable manner.

This goes really against my site rules, but I have no choice. I'm trying to adapt by operating the construction site in accordance with the customs here.

Silencing the bothersome voices of his conscience and telling himself countless times that it was fine, Lloyd continued exploiting the demons. Thankfully, however, that sped things up, and the construction of the railroad bed was finished swiftly. And once he was done, he advanced to constructing tracks right away.

It doesn't have to be grand or complicated. Just good enough for the train transporting the souls to travel north and south at a smooth speed.

There wasn’t any need to construct a complicated or flashy train like those in South Korea. He just needed one that possessed basic functions.

First, we should work on the ballast that will support the tracks on the bed.

Lloyd opted to go for the most traditional option, which was a carpet of gravel to build the ballast.

The gravel on the ground creates friction and absorbs some of the shock and vibration. It’s easy to construct, and the structure itself is simple.

The downsides were that the train created dust as it traveled and was high-maintenance. But he didn’t care.

Dust is not a problem since I’m in Hell, and there are plenty of demons to help with maintenance anyway. So, all’s good.

Currently, over 800,000 demons were mobilized to transport dead souls through carts. And so, once the train was ready to go, many demons were set to be unemployed. The maintenance of the train tracks would solve this massive unemployment issue.

Haah. Let’s get to work! Work!

Laying the gravel was a walk in the park. Hell was full of rocks. All sorts of rocks, which came about as the pyroclastic materials cooled down, scattered all about the area. Lloyd scraped and saved them and laid everything flat on the 86-mile railroad bed. And then, he constructed the ties and rails. His method of construction wasn’t necessarily modern. Sure, he could obviously install the Alternative System, an anti-dust prevention device widely used in developed countries like Germany, the United States, South Korea, and Switzerland.

But I don’t necessarily have to.

It went without saying that modern techniques were useful. The train created less vibration or noise when it traveled. But here, this sort of

technique unnecessarily complicated the construction and delayed its completion.

And besides, the train will be carrying demons and souls, so who cares about their travel experience?

It wasn't Lloyd's problem, and so he opted to use the comparatively old and simple "STEDEF" method.

It's the oldest and simplest method I've studied.

The STEDEF track was invented in France in 1964, and it was widely used in the early days of train-building in South Korea. For instance, it was utilized for subway lines one through four in Seoul city.

"Lay the tie! Then put the rails! Then secure the locks! Follow the Construction Guideline!"

The ties were laid horizontally on the ballast to fasten the rails and distribute the weight. To make those, Lloyd used the centipede legs he had obtained by a large volume by disintegrating the lava centipede and tying them by fours. That resulted in a firm, solid tie. And the rails were installed on the centipede-leg-ties.

And centipede shells were used to create the rails, which the train would directly touch as it moved. Who made it? Javier. How? With the blinding aura he obtained after rising to become a grandmaster.

Slash! One wielding of his sword rendered dozens of aura rays. These rays pounced on the dead centipedes and quickly dismantled their shells in a flash. All the corpses were cut up and perfectly processed with such precision that it made Lloyd's hair stand. Then he carpeted the rails on the ties.

Next, the centipede antennas were used as the lock. Much like tying a cable tie, the ballast was looped through a hole under the rails. Then the ties and rails were fastened to the ballast.

“Ppodong! Step on it!”

“Ppodong!”

Ppodong, who had gotten giant after eating the red sunflower seed, jumped in excitement, his chubby belly and buttock dancing up and down. He stepped on the ties and rails with all of his weight, the booming and blaring sound of thumping and thwacking ringing across the whole place all day. But Lloyd gave no hoot to the din. The reason was simple. This place was Hell.

Why should I care if it’s noisy when no human lives here?

He didn’t have to worry about causing trouble for people nearby with noise or dust during construction. And so, the construction was advancing smoothly. But there was something Lloyd was unaware of. It was about the very noise he didn’t pay any attention to since he was in Hell and it was unpopulated with humans. He was ignorant that the noise was starting to put the construction site in danger.

“Grr! Noisy!” Under the lava lake near the construction site, there was a creature quietly getting some sleep. But now, it was boiling in anger because of the unexpected construction din, much like the ill-mannered neighbor throwing a party at night.

“Grr!” It deliberated whether it should come up and kill everyone. It was the most dangerous and violent creature in the wilderness of Hell. The Lava Giant opened its eyes, feeling a burning anger to destroy everything in sight.

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Chapter 238: Noise Pollution Complaint (1)

“Grrr! Brrr!”

A vast lava lake sat about 1.8 miles off the construction site. It was a peaceful, sticky, and commonplace lake in Hell. But today, something was slightly different. It was boiling with intensity and fierceness that weren’t there before. The reason was simple.

“Grrr!” The Lava Giant slumbering in the bottom of the lava lake tossed and turned, clamping its ears with its hands in irritation. How could it not? It was asleep for the last 20,000 years, and it wanted to sleep for at least 100,000 years more because it would then be able to recharge a bit. That seemed like a satisfactory amount of good sleep. But the reality was cruel for the Lava Giant.

Boom! Thuuump! For the past few days, its senses had been assaulted by blaring noises and annoying vibrations, and the Lava Giant could not figure out where the sounds were coming from. It was too lazy to even try making sense of them and get up to check them out. So, the giant just let it be, thinking the distractions were just a passing ruckus and would soon disappear. It would be best to ignore the disturbances and fall back asleep. But as time progressed, it started to feel its initial thoughts had been wrong.

Boom! Boom! The vibrations lasted for 24 hours, terrorizing the giant every moment of the day. Something kept drumming the lava lake and pierced the giant’s ears as it slept at the bottom.

“Grrr!”

Its eyelashes trembled in annoyance, and its gigantic hands that covered its ears tensed up.

At every thumping, the giant knitted its brows. At every noise that got under its skin, the face of the giant darkened. And at last, it had enough. It ran out of patience.

“Grr! Grrrr!”

The moment its last strand of patience snapped, the Lava Giant opened its eyes and gradually rose, bringing a change in the lake. The stagnant pool of bubbling lava started to absorb into its entire body, becoming a part of the giant. Its already ginormous body started to swell and at last...

“Grrrrrr! Gargh!!”

Once the Lava Giant sucked every drop of the lava in the lake, it rose and stood, its whole body stretching 656 feet in length, and it shot an enraged glare at the plain full of volcanic ash toward the origin of the pestering din and vibration.

“Grrr!”

Since the giant was 656 feet tall and there weren’t any mountains or hills near the area, the giant had a clear vision of the volcanic ash mound stretching horizontally in a straight line, about 1.6 miles away. Thousands of demons were busily moving while grouped together around the mound. The sight set off the giant.

“Grrr!”

It was crystal clear that these demons had been the ones creating all the recent commotions while they built that tall mound for whatever unknown reason. The solution? It was simple.

“I’ll kill them all, grr!”

That was the solution. Kill every demon. Then they wouldn’t make a fuss anymore. The whole place would quiet down again, and it could happily fall asleep again. Resolved, the giant took a step forward.

Boooom! The whole ground shook as it took a step forward with its 104-foot-long blazing foot. Since it had been a while since the giant last walked, it moved slowly until it became more comfortable with its steps. Soon, the

giant’s gait slowly became more aggressive until it reflected all the unhidden rage inside of it.

Thwaaack! The giant ran. Sprinted. Hurtled. Like a storm. Like an earthquake. It reached the 1.6-mile distance in great strides, approaching the construction site with a violent roar and destructive ground tremor. And without a hint of hesitation or concession, it jumped high and trampled on the railroad with all of its weight.

Kaboom! The rails and ties the demons toiled hard for smashed to pieces, and the bed splintered to little bits. One leaping and trampling. About 260 feet of the bed was destroyed without any trace. The same went for the demons.

“Wh-what the?”

“Aaack!!”

“Get down!”

Dozens of demons flew across the air in various directions like bullets, collapsing to the ground and bleeding blue. They screamed as they grasped their wounds. However, those able to voice their pain were the lucky ones compared to the roughly 20 demons who were turned to dust after being trampled without warning.

“I-It’s the Lava Giant!!”

One of the demons that made sense of things screeched aloud. The demons flailing amid the abrupt destruction and demolition stopped dead in their tracks, all of them blanching at the same time in realization.

“The Lava Giant?”

Chills ran down their spines. The Lava Giant was a terrorizing creature that was incomparably strong to the lava centipedes that they had mastered over. There was no one who could stop the Lava Giant except the King of Hell.

What’s the Lava Giant doing here?!

According to stories, their parents had told when they were young, the Lava Giant came out of slumber only once every hundreds of thousands of years. The last time it went berserk was said to be 20,000 years ago. And so, there was supposed to be an obscene amount of time before it went rampant again.

“S-Somebody!” muttered a demon in a panic-stricken voice. “Somebody go report to the King of Hell!”

“Acck! I want to go too!”

“Me too! But the Hell Castle! It’s too far!”

“Then hide! Run!”

Disheartened, the demons threw their tools away and scurried for their lives, hiding or running far away. But there was one thing they didn’t know. It was that the Lava Giant could capture all their movements with its two eyes from a height of 656 feet. Soon, it unleashed a flood of unspeakable violence.

Wham! The Lava Giant softly stomped the ground. Ten demons that chose to hide in the rocks became crushed between them and turned into powder. Those who chose to run away weren’t safe either.

Whoosh! Booom! This time, the gigantic foot of the Lava Giant moved sideways like a broom, sweeping the ground with a swish. That simple gesture covered hundreds of feet. Dozens of demons were killed by the blow like a colony of ants.

“Please! Ack! Save me!”

The demons dashed and ran for their lives, all yelping and running in every direction. But the Lava Giant was merciless. It believed that it could only peacefully sleep when it killed every single demon who had caused a commotion and awakened it. Thinking so, it jumped into action. It trampled, thrashed, hurtled, and blew out air that was thousands of degrees hot onto everything nearby. The demons were killed in groups like swarms

of fruit flies being exterminated with pesticides. The whole land was mixed with violent noises and hurried screams, which were then combined with savage roars and painful screeching. However, unfortunately, they failed to run away because, in the first place, the construction had taken off in a vast open plain. There was no hiding place nor escape route.

“Grr! Grr!”

The Lava Giant grew more fierce, and now, it looked like the giant was having fun massacring the demons. But had it not been for Javier, who stood in its way, the giant would not have stopped the slaughter until thousands more were killed.

“Grr?”

The giant was enjoying its killing spree when it suddenly paused attacking at the sight of a mysterious creature.

“Grrr...?”

A stranger with an ant-like silhouette appeared out of nowhere. It seemed slightly smaller than even the smallest demons. But this creature’s face was amazingly intriguing. Its skin wasn’t red. And instead of a horn on its head, there was silvery fur. The creature dared to look up back at him with its blue eyes. And so, the Lava Giant thought...

“Grrr!”

What a strange-looking demon! What would it feel like to smash that with my palm? The giant didn’t hesitate.

Fwoosh! The giant acted and struck Javier with its giant palm, and just then, his sword shone.

Fwish! Without any other noise or fancy rays of light, the long sword briefly flashed in the air and stirred the space with unbelievably mediocre skill. But next, the giant saw the horrible scene of its palm getting sliced into dozens of pieces. *Thwack!*

“Grr...!”

Dozens of aura strands bloomed along the path his sword swung in. It then engulfed the space like a brilliant net and slayed the giant’s hand into dozens of pieces. The arm, leg, and upper torso weren’t an exception.

“G-grr!”

Thwack! Pow! Thwamp! Its upper torso was sliced into hundreds of pieces, lava gushing out of the wound like blood. And then... everything coagulated back again.

“Grr!”

Whoosh! The chopped upper torso was restored in a snap. The giant rose as if it wasn’t damaged at all. And with a nonchalant gaze, it bent down toward Javier. Javier’s brows quaked. His sword moved once again.

Thwaaack! His sword once again sliced its upper torso, slaying and cutting. But each time, the giant came back to its original shape. Unharmed, it roared.

“Grrragh!”

Lloyd, who was watching the sight from afar, swallowed.

Shoot. What is that?

He was 984 feet off the ground on Ggoming’s back, and he clenched his fists, recalling the sight a while ago. He and Javier were cleaning up the site just a few miles from the place of the incident. He was in a super mood because the job had gone well for the day, and the tracks were functioning very smoothly. That was when a sinister din came, the kind one you hear when a volcano erupts. He turned, saw the whole scene, and wanted to deny what he was seeing.

That giant was raising hell.

Since the construction site was mostly done on a flatland, it granted Lloyd the whole view of the violent giant even a few miles away. From the moment he learned what was happening, he led Ggoming to fly at the utmost speed and saw Javier jumping off to the ground first and stopping the giant with his stormy aura. And he also saw the monster casually restoring its shape.

I think this situation is a bit hopeless.

Lloyd looked below as he nibbled his lips. The Lava Giant and Javier were in a fierce battle, spewing lava.

Slash! Swoosh!

Dozens of aura strands flashed each time Javier moved, and the giant's body was sectioned into hundreds of pieces. But only to be pieced back together.

It's like slicing water with a knife.

Except that the giant wasn't water but more like a boiling soup or curry. Truly, the body of the Lava Giant was like soup or curry. And so, Javier's powerful and perfect aura didn't do any damage. No matter how many times he sliced and cut, its mushy body just went back together. It was like slicing a hot soup or curry. No damage could be done.

This isn't a matter of strength.

Lloyd frowned, his forehead wrinkling.

Javier's strong. He's a grandmaster. And the Lava Giant is getting beaten so badly that it can't even lay its hands on Javier. Still, things are bad even with those conditions. So, this is a matter of quality.

Repeatedly trying to slice into soup that couldn't be sliced. Vigorously wielding a kitchen knife even if it wasn't possible. That summed up the whole fight. In short, Javier was at a laughably bad disadvantage. He even thought that this was the fight that Javier could never win in the first place.

Ha...

Lloyd’s shoulders trembled and racked his brain after heaving a heavy sigh. He analyzed the situation, predicted results, and calculated the best outcome.

It can’t go on like this. We’re stuck. Javier can’t win. Never. The same goes for me. My mana blast and Supercharge won’t work. I don’t know how and where the Lava Giant came from, but if it keeps going berserk like this, the whole construction will go down the drain.

Lloyd accepted this. He didn’t overestimate his abilities. When he objectively judged the situation, he found it to be awfully despairing. But Lloyd didn’t give up. No, he didn’t want to give up.

What if I move the construction site? It sucks to just throw away everything we’ve been building here... But what if I build a new railroad on a different route?

The construction can resume, he thought. Though all the efforts spent in this one would be wasted, though he seriously teared up at the thought of the time and effort poured into surveying, designing, and constructing Lloyd wondered if a new start was the answer. A vague ray of hope appeared amid the blinding darkness. Just then, the Lava Giant roared aloud as it was getting beaten to a pulp.

“Garrrr! I will kill you all! With my rancor for not being able to fall asleep at your commotion! I will kill you all! That strange mound! I will follow you all even to the end of Hell and break everything!”

“...”

The moment Lloyd heard its roar, he thought he was screwed.

The monster was running amok because the noise from the construction site pissed it off? And so what? That strange mound? It’s going to follow us until the end and destroy everything?

Lloyd’s legs gave way. What else could it mean? Now that the construction and commotion had enraged the giant, it was bent on interfering and breaking everything, even if it required following to the end of Hell.

Ha. What even is my life?

His eyes were wet as he started to acutely feel his three months of work going down the drain. But he couldn’t think of another way to stop the giant.

I’m seriously stuck.

The solution to stop the Lava Giant didn’t come to him at all. Team up with Javier? Nothing seemed to change, even if he did. Mobilizing the fantastical creatures looked the same. So, this was a hopeless affair, and it was useless and moot to hold on to it. So the conclusion was...

Cutting it off is the fastest way to minimize my loss.

Lloyd sighed at length. He pulled himself together, telling himself that he should accept defeat this time. He led Ggoming to fly lower.

“Hey!” shouted Lloyd at Javier. “Dude! Let’s run away!”

Lloyd didn’t even wait for his response. This construction was a flop and no doubt about that. He could try out and build a new construction railroad somewhere else, but the Lava Giant would eventually arrive and turn things upside down like now. Constructing anything would be an impossibility. Holding on to it would only waste time without any fruit. And so, Lloyd, who decided to bear the loss, lifted his left hand and concentrated his mind. His mind went to the magic mark in his left hand, which Anticus had explained about the safety measure before he got here.

Was this how I can open the exit from Hell? I think.

Then he activated the Asrahan Core Technique and concentrated the mana on his left hand. It started to tickle, and a magic circle, which was marked

in the left hand like a transparent tattoo, flashed to shoot out a strand of mana in the air.

Ziiing! Clash! Slash! The strand of mana created a circle in the air, and with a crackle, the circle widened to 16 feet in diameter. This was the Hell gate Anticus had provided Lloyd to escape out of Hell. It was the only passage that connected the realms between Hell and the human world where the Lorasia continent was. As he opened it up, Lloyd thought to himself...

I think the dragon said that the area in my world that connects to Hell gate is random. I pray that it's near the Frontera fiefdom.

Lloyd was exhausted now. The construction in Hell was on the brink of failure, and the contract with the Hell of King was over. And he won't be able to release the soul of the ancient dragon, and it'd be impossible to attain membership in the Dragon King club. He was drained. Empty. Now, Lloyd just wanted to rest.

Right. Like I'd be able to enjoy the assistance from the Dragon King and two lives. I should just take good care of my one life and live well in comfort.

Lloyd decided that he should be content with what he has now. Stop now, and rest up. And so, now that he was escaping out of Hell, he wished that he'd arrive at a place near his fiefdom to get home and take a break even a tiny second faster. Wishing to enjoy a carefree, peaceful, and comfortable life a tiny bit earlier, Lloyd stared at the Hell gate. At the same time, the gate was completed.

Spark! Whoosh! A spark crackled. Wind from the human world blew through the gate. The wind felt like 14 Fahrenheit.

Whoosh!

Eek...?

The gust of freezing wind blew so suddenly that Lloyd hugged his clothes tighter.

What the heck?

Feeling dismayed, Lloyd tossed his glance to the other end of the gate. He then saw the scene inside the Hell gate.

That's...

There was a sea. But not just any kind of sea. The whole water was frosty with a sheet of slushy ice on top. And there were glaciers floating around. So, that was...

A polar region?

Lloyd had opened the Hell gate in his desperate attempt to run away. When Lloyd made sense of the scene...

"Grrr! Achew!" For the first time, the Lava Giant, which was going berserk, sneezed helplessly as its whole body gave a terrible shiver.

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Chapter 239: Noise Pollution Complaint (2)

“Grrr! Achoo!”

The Lava Giant gave a hard tremble, and it belched a terrible sneeze as it bent over. Its lava snot spewed in all directions and burned the land. Seeing that, Lloyd thought to himself...

Eh? Come on... It is so rude to sneeze without a mask... Wait, that’s not what’s important. Is the Lava Giant vulnerable to cold?

Lloyd received a feeling as if a bell tolled in his head with a clear ding. The Hell gate had been opened to provide an escape for Lloyd, but it had to be connected to the polar region out of all the places in the world of the living. However, this thankfully brought a gust of biting wind through the gate and caused the Lava Giant to pitifully shiver in front of it. It hugged around its arms in pity, constantly sneezing and slouching its neck.

“Grr! Achoo! Grr! Ichoo! Grr! Watchoo!”

At the sight, Lloyd became curious. But curiosity soon turned into suspicion, which evolved into a possibility. Then that started to shine in his head as a vague hope.

It could work. Let’s first check it out!

Lloyd held up the shovel in Ggoming’s saddle and activated his two circles lightly. Causing them to collide, he stretched out a shovel at the same time. *Kaboom!*

The mana blast jetted out dozens of feet from the shovel and hit one shoulder of the shivering Lava Giant. *Thwack!*

“Grr!”

The Lava Giant shot a glare at him. Lloyd immediately raised Ggoming’s reins in fear and soared high in the air to dodge the giant’s attack. Then he

observed the giant’s shoulder that was hit with his mana blast.

Please... I hope my guess is right.

Desire and hope filled Lloyd’s eyes. If he was right, he really believed that he could defeat the Lava Giant, and the railroad construction didn’t have to be abandoned. All of his efforts poured into this place didn’t have to go down the drain.

So, please!

Lloyd’s desire-filled gaze pricked the shoulders of the giant. Meanwhile, its shoulder slowly started to regenerate.

“Grr!”

Reminiscent of boiling curry, its shoulder was made of bubbling lava. The hole, which was about 25 inches wide and 9.8 feet deep, was easily restored despite the hit from the mana blast. But the restoration speed was...

It has gotten slower!

Lloyd’s eyes glimmered. He was certain. The speed had slowed down. Though it was just a small hole, way smaller than the damage taken by Javier’s blow, the restoration took place slower than the first one. It was clear. Lloyd thought he knew why.

The wind from the polar region has cooled its body down.

That was the reason. It was actually a simple principle. It was easy to think of it as a boiling pot of curry. Hot curry was impossible to bore a hole or slice into when it was boiling. The holes would be easily filled again regardless of how many times you sliced or stabbed it.

But what would happen if the curry was cold?

It thickened. Solidified. Anybody who refrigerated curry in a plastic container before would easily understand what was happening.

Hardened curry can be sliced with a knife or bore a hole!

The lava appeared to be the same. Lloyd figured that once the temperature dropped and the lava solidified, the giant wouldn't be able to quickly restore itself like now.

I can do it. This is doable. How lucky am I!

Gliding through the gust of biting wind that started to swirl through Hell's sky, Lloyd stared at the Hell gate with eyes full of tears.

Ah, my good-luck charm!

At this moment, the Hell gate looked like the most precious piece of treasure in his eyes. He had just opened it in order to escape. Thus, it never occurred to him that it would connect to the polar region and grant him hope for victory.

"Okay, time to knuckle down! Ggoming!" called Lloyd.

"Ggoming!" exclaimed Ggoming.

"Let's get down first!"

"Ggomiming!"

Ggoming flew lower against the wind, and just when he thought he was in Javier's earshot, Lloyd shouted, "Javier!"

Javier responded to the shout by throwing a glance at Lloyd about 200 yards away.

"There! Above you! Do you see the Hell gate in the air?"

Javier nodded. Infusing his voice with more mana, Lloyd boomed, "There! The cold air is coming out now! The giant is growing cold because of that! I think! We can defeat it!"

Javier nodded again. He, too, had been feeling the same way.

It’s all because of the Hell gate Master Lloyd has opened up.

Javier saw the Lava Giant shivering against the cold wind, and it was clear that the freezing wind was the cause as Lloyd shouted to him just then. In that case, the giant wouldn’t be able to heal as fast as it did a while ago.

I must play my part here without any mistakes.

Javier remembered how Lloyd had come to Hell because of his trust in him. So, he could not let Master Lloyd down. He had to get the job done, even if it was dangerous. Javier believed that was his primary duty while escorting his young master through Hell, to begin with.

Grab! Veins bulged on the back of his hand that grabbed the sword. From that moment, Javier’s offense started to become fiercer.

Slash! Without any mercy or hesitation, with nothing but conviction, Javier slashed and slayed on repeat. With only one target in mind, his sword cut, slashed, and sliced into every part of the Lava Giant’s body.

“Grrr! Achoo! Grrr! Grr!”

The Lava Giant had been flabbergasted by the sudden freezing coldness. And now, the giant was at a loss in front of Javier’s attacks which were growing more brutal by the second. Its whole body was sliced and slashed by the aura, but it regenerated the wounds nonetheless. Its regeneration speed, however, gradually slowed down as the cold winds cooled its temperature. Eventually, the giant realized that it could die if the current situation continued. It didn’t think it would remain intact if the silver-haired knight struck down on its cold and hardened body. As such, it arrived at one conclusion.

“See you next time! Achoo! Grrrr!”

The giant wheeled around as it received dozens of aura slashes, openly exposing its back to Javier. And it started to run as it limped.

“Eh? Could it be?!” Lloyd mumbled as he watched the scene from the sky. Just then, he was gripped with an ominous feeling. The feeling brewed in him, strong and thick like a broth that had been cooking for ten years And soon, his premonition turned into reality.”

Stomp! Stomp! Stomp!

“That bastard! It’s getting away!” Lloyd shrieked. And it really was. The Lava Giant was bolting away as the situation was becoming unfavorable for it.

What kind of monster does that?

Lloyd almost grabbed the back of his neck in stress. How could he not? That monster appeared out of the blue and ransacked the whole construction scene and ignored Lloyd’s effort to stop it. Yet, now it was running away right when it was put in a slightly disadvantageous position?

“Don’t lose it!” Lloyd’s shout grew more hurried, but it wasn’t simply because he was nettled by the giant’s opportunistic behavior.

If we lose the giant now, the construction is really over!

Lloyd was certain of it. If he lost the Lava Giant now and failed to stop it once and for all, he may never get a chance to catch it again in the future.

I don’t know about the others, but I’m sure of that. Without a doubt. I’ll never get another opportunity to kill it, if not now!

The reason was simple. The Hell gate that he had just opened up could only bring in a limited amount of wind. Those sharp winds couldn’t go very far out.

Of course. The wind may be freezing cold, but it’s coming through a hole only a few dozen feet wide. But Hell is so vast compared to that!

To analogize, this was the same as installing an air conditioner only good for a small room in a giant mansion.

In that case, it's only cool at the very front of the air conditioner. It quickly gets hot once you move away from it by even a little.

Just then, Lloyd recalled his life in South Korea, particularly the searing days of summer. It went without saying that his room didn't have an air conditioner. It'd be a luxury for him, given that his room was the oldest and cheapest one in the market. And so, on days when the heat was deadly and unbearable, he used to head to nearby banks and residence centers to get some cool air for free.

But it wasn't a heavenly place. The people there used the lowest setting on the air conditioner to reduce their electricity bill. How cheap!

The bank was large, but the air conditioner was quite weak. And so, Lloyd had to stay right in front of the air conditioner to get the cool air. Thanks to this valuable experience, he was able to see through the Lava Giant right away.

It knows that the cold air will disappear as soon as it moves away from this area!

The giant knew that it had to get away from this place, far from the Hell gate until the cold winds became warm again. Soon afterward, its body would run hot again and wouldn't receive any damage from being attacked. Its invincible body would be back.

I'm sure that is the giant's line of thought. But what if things do develop according to its plan? I'll neither be able to kill it nor put a stop to it. The construction project extends outside this area after all. The railroad stretches 86 miles long!

In other words, if it slipped away today and decided in the future to continue disrupting construction, there was a chance for the giant to wreak havoc at any time when it was outside the reach of the winds coming from the Hell gate. This meant that he and Javier's efforts to stop it would be meaningless.

I can open the Hell gate only once. Nowhere else. I can keep this gate opened like this, but I can't open additional gates.

And so, the Lava Giant must be caught here. The first step in achieving that goal was stopping it from running.

"Get it!" Lloyd shouted with a pleading heart. "Attack its legs first!"

Lloyd picked up the shovel and urged Ggoming to fly. From that moment, Lloyd launched a series of attacks on the Lava Giant in the sky while Javier did so from the ground. Lloyd ceaselessly used the triple mana blast, striking the giant's knees and shins. Javier joined his efforts and slashed and swung down on its lower torso over and over again. Each time it was attacked, blood-like lava dripped and burst out from its two legs. And soon, it started to limp from losing heat, which slowed down its regeneration. But...

"Grr! Grrr!"

Lava Giant couldn't be stopped. Even when its limping grew much more evident and dragging more explicit, the Lava Giant moved its two feet without ever stopping, each big step taking itself far away from the Hell gate. At the same time, Lloyd's face darkened.

Shoot!

The giant couldn't be resisted. It couldn't be pinned to the ground. Even with the bluster of freezing wind from the polar region, it was impossible to freeze the inside of that huge lava lump. Only the outside was being cooled, so countless thrashings and piercings and slayings had no effect. Just some delay, but the regeneration didn't stop. Realizing that the corners of Lloyd's eyes teared up a little.

The giant is too big. I need a giant, a big one, to stop it with force in moments like these. That would be just perfect. Oh, I wish I had Bibeong with me!

A bitter pang of regret filled Lloyd’s heart as he thought that things would be different if Bibeong was here.

Bibeong is 328 feet tall. He’s also chubby and heavy.

Though the Lava Giant was twice bigger than him, it seemed plausible for Bibeong to hang on its legs and drag it down when it had such a bad limp. But that was a meaningless fantasy, and he knew that.

I shouldn’t have lent Bibeong to the queen for free. You idiot!

If he could, Lloyd wanted to go back to four months ago, clutch his collar, and shout at himself to either keep Bibeong or ask for a high rental fee. In particular, to not give anything for free even family members didn’t lend each other things for free. Lloyd wanted to yell into the ears of his past self at the top of his lungs.

Dammit. Dammit!

The construction seemed to end with a debacle because he had thoughtlessly lent Bibeong like a fool. Now, the strand of hope that had appeared in front of his eyes was ripped apart. His three months’ worth of efforts were about to go down the drain. He was about to fail in rescuing the dragon's soul and obtaining the Dragon King’s support.

Why did you have to lend him for free, Lloyd?!

His eyes were wet now because he regretted his decision too sordidly. Meanwhile, the Lava Giant continued to make a run, still limping. Even though Javier was still throwing auras with greater ferocity, the Lava Giant didn’t cease its run.

“Ha...”

Lloyd had seen a faint ray of hope when the Hell gate opened with a flurry of cold wind. But now, there really was no other method. He had to admit that. He let out a sigh.

Lloyd stared at the back of the Lava Giant, feeling helpless and empty like when someone else snatched the last Buy 1 Get 1 Free noodle pack left in the supermarket. And so, it was unbeknownst to Lloyd that he held another solution, a hopeful one. In the Arctic Sea not so far off from the Hell gate, the Bone Dragon, the youngest recruit in the Skeleton Corps, was there. It was there, dutifully following Lloyd's order to stay low in the Arctic Sea when it sensed Lloyd's presence. *Clack!*

It's Lloyd! This is the smell of Master Lloyd!

Splash! Like a puppy that smelled the owner after a long time, the Bone Dragon was tickled pink. And it threw its head out of the water with a splash and discovered the Hell gate overhead.

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Chapter 240: Noise Pollution Complaint (3)

Northern sea. Three days ago, the Bone Dragon had arrived at the bitter cold polar region where there was only ice, biting wind, and waves. It was there to fulfill the order of its master, Lloyd.

Lay low in the northern sea of the capital for a while.

The assignment had become the Bone Dragon's sole point of focus. Lloyd was the first master it served after being dominated by the Zombie Domination skill, and so, the Bone Dragon loved its master, Lloyd. It yearned to be praised, and that required complying with his orders. So, it flew north day and night until a sea appeared. It was satisfied for a split second until it realized it shouldn't be content. The sea stretched north without an end in sight.

Clack! North. North and only north. To the most northern part. Lloyd had told the Bone Dragon to hide in the northern sea. It believed that it would be lavished with praise once it traveled far north of this world.

With that thought, a sense of excitement rushed through the Bone Dragon. It started to put more force into its fluttering wings. Toward the north, it flew on and on in almost religious zeal until the dragon finally arrived at the sea of the polar region, which sat far north of the planet.

Clack! The Bone Dragon shook its large skull as soon as it arrived at the destination and studied the planet's magnetic field with the magnetite laden in its horn. Thanks to that, it confirmed in satisfaction that it was in the far north. This meant that Lloyd would shower the dragon with praise as long as it quietly stayed hidden in there. Filled with satisfaction and conviction, the Bone Dragon dove into the sea, breaking several feet of ice and enjoying a cold bath. But its original plan turned out to be quite a challenge as the neighbors were very cold to the newcomer.

Gaargh!

The first resident of the sea that took action was the Gigatitan. It boasted a body length of 295 feet and a weight of 2,500 tons. And it also possessed a shock-absorbing shell. The Gigatitan was a sea monster with a formidable physique. However, in the presence of the Bone Dragon, it was nothing but a pestering lobster.

Clack! Flick! The Bone Dragon sent a flick at the Gigatitan, who scurried away in fear for its life with just one blow. And the dragon felt a wave of boundless trust for Lloyd, realizing the greatness of its master once again from the stately battle.

“If monsters like the Gigatitan try to harass you, just flick them with your foreleg. You’re stronger.”

Master Lloyd had assured it so, and his words turned out to be true. This excited the Bone Dragon even more, which marked the beginning of its ruthless attacks against the northern sea monsters that tried to pick a fight with the newcomer trespassing on their territory. The emperor whale that was as big as the gigatitan yet faster, the ginormous shark Teralodon that had a charming set of straight teeth, and the strongest predator of the sea, Kraken. They were all beaten with a light flick from the dragon. And sooner or later, the most powerful predators at the top of the underwater ecosystem appeared. The Mermaid Corps.

“We can no longer sit and watch the monster guided by evil magic defile the sea! My dear sisters!”

“Streamline with flexibility and force!”

“Dolphin kick without any hesitation or restraint!”

“Sisters, advance!”

The mermaids were indeed powerful. It wasn’t possible for them to not be strong. This was especially true looking at the swimmers on the earth. Michael Phelps, the best swimmer in the world who held eight Olympic gold medals, was told to undergo six hours of hectic training each day. And such hellish training was done for six days every week.

But what about the mermaids? They swam for 24 hours! Seven days a week! Swimming was a way of life for them, a part of their identity. And so, their bodies were a weapon in every sense of the word.

They owned a physique that made a sturdy Olympian look like a child in comparison. Their shoulders were as wide as the Pacific Ocean, their pecs were thick enough to bounce off meteors, their abs were so defined that one could literally use them as a washboard, and their veins were so vivid that they looked like worms. They were swimmers who spent their entire lives going through extreme and hardcore training under the ocean. Furthermore, there were 1,000 of those terrifying mermaids.

They had enough strength to easily dismember most Gigatitans in three parts—their head, chest, and stomach—in under 30 seconds. But how did the Bone Dragon react when it was faced with the charging Mermaid Corps? It was in high spirits.

Clack! Clack!

The mermaids were too fast for the dragon to flick them. When it was lucky and managed to strike, they simply endured the pain with the thick shield of their muscles and got back on their feet. There was considerable force behind their strikes. However, their attack only made for a relaxing and rejuvenating massage for the dragon’s tense bones and joints after its long flight here. The mermaids also had great endurance. Their impressive lung capacity was what allowed them to prolong the battle for three days straight without losing momentum.

Thanks to them, the Bone Dragon wasn’t ever bored during those three days after it arrived at the polar region. I was happy and felt fulfilled. The dragon wished it could share this joy with its Master.

However, it knew that was impossible since Lloyd was in Hell. The Bone Dragon thought that was a pity. That could be why the dragon felt elated when it suddenly sensed Lloyd’s mana nearby.

Clack! At first, the Bone Dragon thought it was dreaming. But no, it undoubtedly sensed Lloyd’s mana. The mutual location tracking feature of

the Zombie Domination skill had been deactivated ever since Lloyd went to Hell, but it had started to work again. So, the Bone Dragon could tell that its master was near!

Clack! Clack! Splash! The Bone Dragon snapped its head up, tossing its glance toward the sky above the sea where Lloyd's mana was coming from. Then it saw the 16-foot tall Hell gate hanging in the air about 328 feet from the sea and felt the heat of Hell flowing out from it. In addition, it sensed the region's time zone starting to adjust to that of Hell. The moment the Bone Dragon perceived the adjustment, it was convinced that Lloyd was on the other end of the Hell gate.

Kaboom! In sheer onrush of joy, the Bone Dragon flung itself high from the sea, wagging its pelvis and shaking off the mermaids glued to it. Then it made its way toward the Hell gate. However, it failed to enter inside.

Thump! The Bone Dragon was too big to pass through the Hell gate, which was only 16 feet in diameter. But it wasn't flustered as there was another way to get to the other end.

Claaack! The Bone Dragon took apart all its joints, from its large skull to its pelvis. And after that, it lined the bones up in the air, leading each one to pass through the Hell gate like a railroad car. Afterward, it flew into Hell without hesitation and pieced back its body again.

Claaack! Clack! Clack! Once it was done with the assembly, it surveyed the area. The landscape of this place was poles apart from the polar region it was a while ago. In a flash, it located Lloyd.

Clack! The Bone Dragon spotted Lloyd flying low on the parrotbill, so it zoomed off at an explosive speed toward him and landed nearby. With a banging, crushing sound, the Bone Dragon wagged its tail, even flipping over and revealing its belly to show its happiness. It waited earnestly for Lloyd to praise it.

But instead, Lloyd cried out, "Hey! Let's skip the pleasantries since we're short on time! If you're here, do what you came here for! Catch that thing!"

Creak? The Bone Dragon cocked its head to the side in confusion and tried to make sense of Lloyd's lukewarm response to its happy greeting. No, Master Lloyd had shouted at it as if he was in a panic. The Bone Dragon wanted to know why he was acting like that, so it turned to the direction where he was pointing at. And there, the Bone Dragon spotted the Lava Giant stomping away. Just then, the Bone Dragon's eyes were filled with rage.

Clack! It's because of that giant. That giant stirred Lloyd into a panic. That giant prevented it from getting a warm welcome from Lloyd. Therefore, that giant must be destroyed!

Claaack! Enraged, the Bone Dragon leaped from the ground, flying across hundreds of feet in one leap and landing right in front of the Lava Giant. And it grabbed its enemy.

Boooom! The Bone Dragon and the Lava Giant. The two monsters with similar physiques collided. For the first time, the unstoppable escapade of the Lava Giant came to a pause.

"Grrrrr? Grr?"

The Lava Giant's eyes widened when the Bone Dragon suddenly appeared and grabbed it. Confusion rushed through its mind, and it wanted to wrench off the other's grip. However, the giant couldn't.

"Grrragh! Grr-!"

So, the Lava Giant breathed out lava fire at the head of the Bone Dragon and clutched the ribs of its intruder with a boiling-hot lava grip. The Lava Giant expected its opponent to panic at the heat, but that was incorrect. The dragon didn't react to the heat at all, and the reason was very simple. Quite literally, the dragon was nothing but bones. As a result, the hot lava felt more like a heated blanket to the creature.

Claaack! The Bone Dragon showed greater strength, causing the Lava Giant to slowly step back in alarm.

Watching the situation, Lloyd yelled, “Good! Keep pushing it!”

Lloyd inwardly exclaimed in joy. The Bone Dragon showed up just in time and stopped the Lava Giant from getting away. Lloyd’s eyes were full of pride and affection as they gazed at the youngest member of the Skeleton Corps.

My precious little boy!

Truth be told, Lloyd never expected the Bone Dragon to show up. Why would he? About four months ago, right before he crossed over to Hell, he had ordered the Bone Dragon to hide in the northern sea of the capital. It never occurred to Lloyd that the dragon would take his order so seriously and hide all the way in the polar region.

But then I could feel that lovable dragon of mine approaching me.

He felt so from the mutual location tracking feature available in the Zombie Domination skill, which he had used to recruit the Bone Dragon. He sensed it was nearby, moving closer to him. Lloyd was overjoyed. And so now, it was time to finish off the Lava Giant that ruined his construction site.

“Javier! Let’s go!”

It was time for an all-out attack. While the Bone Dragon was holding on to the giant and causing its body to cool near the Hell gate, Lloyd had to finish off the Lava Giant.

If his plan succeeded, he could complete the construction and reap the massive rewards of his months of hard work. With that mindset, Lloyd grabbed the shovel and urged Ggoming to fly. He coordinated with Javier on the ground, hurtling toward the Lava Giant right then and laying a series of attacks without holding back on anything.

Kaboom! Starting with the mana blast and the triple mana blast, Lloyd aimed at the giant’s knees, ankles, back, and other joints. He even aimed at its most private area, although it was a bit of a low blow. The Lava Giant

was shaken and flinched. Of course, its wounds regenerated soon enough as the lava hadn't completely fooled yet. However, Lloyd didn't care.

If hitting isn't enough, then I just have to keep going until it is!

Lloyd decided to tie the giant to the ground until the lava grew completely cold. To that end, he had to give everything to hitting the monster even though it seemed hopeless. He needed to slash, pierce, and damage the giant as much as possible. That was the only way to ensure the arctic wind blowing through the Hell gate would cool its body.

Duh! When you're drinking hot broth, you don't just stare at it until it cools down! You whisk it with a spoon and blow at it!

The same principle applied here. He would create holes into its body with the mana blast, and Javier's aura would add more of them. Jab, penetrate, slash. And as its whole body became damaged, the hot lava inside it would naturally be exposed to the cold wind. The heat would then escape faster. But Lloyd didn't stop there. He instead used every means possible to steal the heat from the giant's body. One method he used involved Hamang.

"Hamang!" Lloyd called earnestly. "It's always hot here, right?"

"Hamang?"

"How would you like to drink ice water?"

"Hamang!"

"Then go and spray it here!"

Lloyd threw Hamang to the other end of the Hell gate. More specifically, he was thrown across the air into the polar region from Hell. Hamang plunged into the Arctic Sea and started to drink salty water to his heart's content.

"Hamang! Hamamamang!" *Sluuurp! Swoosh!* His body grew 229 feet tall in a wink. Next, he spewed the water downward.

"Humu-mung!"

Thwack! The violent water stream sent Hamang 328 feet off the ground, and he instantly changed the direction of the water jet toward the Lava Giant visible through the Hell gate.

Swaaa! The gush of icy water passed the Hell gate in a straight line, like tap water jetting out of a hose. In return, this forced the giant, who was exposed to the arctic winds while being held in place by the Bone Dragon, to take a freezing shower on top of everything.

“Grrrr! Achoo!”

The giant’s sneezing grew worse. And its temperature started to drop at a faster speed amid the thick volume of vapor.

“Don’t stop! Keep going!” Lloyd encouraged more earnestly.

Javier’s attack grew fiercer. Hamang continued to shoot water on repeat. The Bone Dragon took hold of the giant with more tenacity. The body of the Lava Giant cooled at a faster speed. This slowed down the damage regeneration speed.

And its movement started to grow duller. As though it was freezing up by the merciless coldness, the giant’s boiling red skin started to thicken and turn black. The inside shown between the cracks started to blacken a little by little as well. And just when Lloyd judged that it was hardened enough, Lloyd bawled.

“Now!“

At Lloyd’s shouting, the Bone Dragon pushed the giant, which caused it to stagger back. When the distance between the two increased for the first time, Javier rushed in between.

Swoosh! With his feet on the land made of volcanic ash, cutting through the heat, he coldly passed an eye over the Lava Giant.

...!

Silently, hundreds of aura strands swept over the Lava Giant without giving it any time to think. And next, welcoming messages started to pour down in front of Lloyd.

Ding Dong!

[You have appropriately made use of your wisdom, unexpected luck, and trustworthy allies. Thanks to that, you have succeeded in destroying the living disaster of Hell, the Lava Giant Dunkleos.]

[For this miraculous battle, you are awarded a legendary title.]

[You have earned a new title.]

[A new title <Frozen Hands, Frozen Feet> has been created.]

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Chapter 241: Hell Express Ticket (1)

[A new title <Frozen Hands, Frozen Feet> has been created.]

Eek?!

Lloyd swallowed as he looked at the message floating in front of his eyes. His glance flicked over to the Lava Giant that was being chopped into hundreds of pieces.

“Grrrr!”

The giant let out a shriek before it died. Its cry grew faint until it was heard no more. Instead, the thudding sound of rocks hitting the ground reverberated in the air. *Boom! Crash! Thump!*

The searing hot rocks were half-solidified. It looked like they could no longer be fused back together.

They’ve cooled down too much for that.

Lloyd clenched his fists. Javier’s sword deeply pierced into the giant’s body when it was sufficiently cooled. With that, the giant had finally been defeated. The message that appeared in front of Lloyd’s eyes proved it.

Let’s see.

Collecting his breath, Lloyd read the message.

[Frozen Hands, Frozen Feet]

[Title Level: Scary Story]

The Lava Giant is scary. The Lava Giant is hot. The Lava Giant is violent. So shh. You can never anger the giant. That is what we believed in. The King of Hell is busy. Hell’s Knights hate doing rough work. We never dared to call them, so we just got beaten up. We thought staying low was the answer in life. But it wasn’t. There was always a way.

Lloyd Frontera, that human. I never expected that human to start this. Wonder what it is? Let's close the door first if you want to hear it. The cold wind is blowing... A-achoo!

[Compliment Effect: You have played a critical role in destroying the most dangerous and violent creature in Hell, the Lava Giant. Thousands of demons clearly saw your feat, and this heroic tale will spread across Hell. Thanks to that, you will be feared and respected by the demons equal to Hell's Knight. Moreover, you will not suffer from hypothermia in cold climates and will not freeze to death.]

[Title Region: All Hell regions. All areas whose annual average climate is 32 °F and below.]

[Active Period of Title: 120 Years (Human world)/ 100,000 Years (Hell)]

[A title's powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region for which the compliment was given. Moreover, time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 6]

[Current CP: 1,142]

Wow.

A smile hung from one ear to the other, and Lloyd couldn't suppress it.

This title has an amazing effect too.

Lloyd could sense the power of this new title the moment he saw it.

First, about the part where I'll be feared and respected like Hell's Knights by the demons of Hell. This is going to help me out considerably in the remaining construction moving forward.

The railroad construction had been a challenge because it was taking place in the special environment of Hell, relying on special laborers, the demons. Ensuring that the construction went smoothly was a hellish job.

How could it not? The lava makes the ground unstable all the time, and the demons are an infamously unruly bunch. Ha… Just thinking about this is making me go bald from stress.

It was a burden he had been carrying alone for the past three months. Among the existing difficulties, the issue that gave Lloyd the hardest time was controlling the demons. They were extremely disobedient.

Without Javier's constant surveillance, 20,000 of the 30,000 demons would have run away already.

Demons, in the first place, were impossible to correct. So, he could only use force to put them to work. The problem was that doing so put a burden on him.

As soon as I pay less attention to the construction site, I will lose my authority over them right away.

Then the construction field would quickly descend into chaos. At worst, it would become a complete disaster. There were similar instances in South Korea very rarely where construction went down in flames. Lloyd had seen it himself and heard about it too.

But now, that concern is off my shoulders.

In the hierarchy of Hell, the Hell's Knights were right beneath the King of Hell. Thanks to the title, Lloyd now held equal authority as the knights. And he looked forward to having a proportionately easier time controlling the demons.

Plus, there's the immunity to hypothermia and freezing to death. This is another awesome effect.

This effect wasn't useful in Hell, where the whole place boiled with heat. But if he ever traveled to a numbingly cold region? The effect would be extremely useful.

I learned this from direct experience when I came down to Hell.

The title he had obtained by building the Qanat back in the sultan's kingdom came to his mind. "The Top Gun from the West." This new title had a similar effect to that one.

The effect that prevents me from getting dehydrated in desert regions with an annual climate of 104 °F and above.

Lloyd was able to survive in Hell all this time because of that effect. He could stay here in comfort even when Javier was sweating bullets from the suffocating heat. The effect he had acquired proved to be extremely useful in this place, at least. And what about the effect he had acquired from this new title?

You never know. I might visit a cold region sometime in my life.

Therefore, the more effects like these he had, the better off he was. Similar to accumulating antibodies from a vaccine, hoarding titles always helped in the long run. Lloyd then closed the message with immense happiness. But earning a new title wasn't the only thing that filled his heart with satisfaction.

I can resume the construction now.

It had been a laborious three months to get to this point. The roadbed had just been completed, and he was in the middle of working on the ties. In other words, the construction was soon to be over in a month or two. Now that the threat of his efforts going down in flames was solved, he could continue working in peace. His pounding heart calmed down a little. Relieved, Lloyd rushed to Javier first.

"Hey," Lloyd called, "are you all right?"

"Yes, thankfully." Javier was catching his raspy breath, with the debris of the giant all scattered around him. His whole body was soaked with sweat. It made sense.

Even though there was cold air coming out from the Hell gate, he ran around and fought against the Lava Giant in this place filled with fire and

smoke. Thankfully, he doesn't look like he's hurt anywhere.

Lloyd studied Javier with concern filling his gaze. However, he spoke in contrary to those feelings of his.

"Are you hot?" blurted Lloyd.

"Yes, a little..." gasped Javier.

"Tsk. You're a weakling." Lloyd shook his head.

"..."

"Who cares if you're a grandmaster and can shoot auras? This much heat is enough to make you get soaked in sweat. Am I wrong?" Lloyd smirked and lashed out at Javier.

Javier removed a sweaty strand of hair stuck on his forehead. "I may be sweating a lot, but come to think of it, I think I am in a better state than you."

"Excuse me?" shrilled Lloyd. "You are in a better state than me?"

"Yes."

"How?"

"Even when I am soaked in sweat and covered with ash, I am better looking than you at your cleanest, Master Lloyd. "

"..."

"I feel thrilled whenever I realize this fact," gloated Javier with a smug "It never gets old. Nothing is better than being handsome."

Lloyd inwardly wished for all disgustingly beautiful people to get hemorrhoids. He wondered if this was what it felt like to fire a tiny bullet with a slingshot while giggling, only to be shot back with a 14-ton GBU-57

MOP. Blinking back bitter tears, Lloyd cried, “Hey, you think this is the time to prattle?”

Javier said nothing, dumbstruck.

“Can’t you see that the construction is a mess? We have to hurry and take care of it. You don’t have time to just sit back and catch your breath. Come on.”

Still, Javier stared at Lloyd without saying anything.

“Come on! Move it. Hurry,” urged Lloyd.

“...”

Lloyd forced Javier to stand up while he was catching his breath. He heartlessly pushed the knight’s back and started cleaning up the site. Even then, the faint smile hanging on his mouth didn’t disappear. To Lloyd's relief, the unexpected crisis had been overcome, and Javier was safe. That alone was enough for him. Now, it was time to clean up the site.

***

The construction field was cleaned up in no time. Though more than a thousand demons had died, which Lloyd was apologetic and hurting for, and about 300 yards of the roadbed were destroyed by the Lava Giant’s stomping, most of the demons had survived. So, the bed was able to be quickly restored. Moreover, the team gained a giant crane, no, an additional member. It was the Bone Dragon.

Clack! Creak! The Bone Dragon, who joined the team late, worked harder than anyone else. It unwaveringly abided by the rule for the undead to not receive any wages or breaks. If there was one thing the dragon aspired to gain from working, it was praise from Lloyd.

“Hey?”

Clack!

“Can you scoop out the lava pooled over there?” Lloyd pointed to an area.

Clack!

“Good. Good job. Now, let’s fill the hole you left behind with volcanic ash. Make sure to thoroughly flatten it out with your feet.”

Clack! Creak!

“My, good boy! As a reward, I’ll give you a name. How about Draggy?”

Clack! Creak!

The Bone Dragon was more motivated to work now that it was named as a reward. Thanks to its zealous attitude, the other fantastical creatures were motivated as well.

“Ppo, Bang, Ha, Ggo!”

Just a few months ago, all of them fought tooth and nail against the Bone Dragon. But what about now? They still did, but not for the same reason. They weren’t very happy about the Bone Dragon, the new recruit in their group, getting all the spotlight in the construction field and even receiving a new name. A fierce sense of competition burned inside them. They resolved to show off their true skills and worked with inextinguishable zeal to reclaim their glory.

“Ppodong! Ppododong!”

Ppodong engrossed himself in cleaning up the leftover soil from where the roadbed was constructed. He blew on the hot volcanic ash and put them inside his cheeks, moving as quickly as he could. At the same time, Bangul knuckled down to produce rebars.

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

Even if this place was hot, there were still areas that required the usage of rebars. One instance of this was in attaching the abutment between the rails made of centipede shells. Similar to melted silicone from a silicone gun, the

rebars held different materials together. As for Hamang, he played his part to the best of his ability as well.

“Humung! Humu-mung!”

Splash! Hamang guzzled the hot spring water in various places of Hell to his heart’s content, and he soon became a 229-foot tall giant roller. Rolling around the construction site, he flattened the areas that needed his contribution. Ggoming also worked hard every day, the same as the rest of the others.

“Hey, Ggoming! Let’s gooo!” said Lloyd.

“Ggoming!” exclaimed Ggoming.

Ggoming flew around the construction site carrying Lloyd until his wings developed a heat rash. The demons joined the momentum and labored in the construction site with greater earnestness. Lloyd now held the same amount of authority as Hell’s Knight, and the demons listened to all of his commands regardless of how menial a chore was. And so, thanks to everyone’s zealous contribution, the construction field was restored in a blink of an eye. The tie construction picked up speed as well, progressing at a scary pace.

The gravel ballast was laid out tightly, and a transverse sleeper was chosen as the method to lay the tie to distribute the weight of the train and maintain the gauge of a track. Next, the standard-length rail, 82 feet in length, was processed from the centipede shells and tucked in the ground. They were then bonded as if they were welded like melted rebars. The last part of the construction was the platform. That, too, wasn’t particularly complicated or difficult to complete.

In the first place, I only need to create two stations. One at the Hell Castle and the other at the edge of Hell.

The starting point and destination. He could only fashion two stations at both ends. Lloyd decided to simplify the structure of the stations to guarantee swift construction and easy maintenance.

It doesn’t have to be complicated. I just need to lay rails on two sides and place a concrete platform in the middle of them. It’s not like the train will hold any fussy passengers. It just needs to conveniently transport a large number of souls.

Lloyd thus focused his efforts on maximizing the space in the platform. The space needed to be vast, so the demons wouldn’t get caught in traffic as they loaded and unloaded innumerable souls. A massive amount of rebars and volcanic ash concrete were utilized. Accordingly, the demons poured their blood, sweat, and tears into the project without ever leaving the work site.

It took one whole month to finish the platform. And finally, 984-foot long and 328-foot wide platforms were built at both ends, one in the Hell Castle and another in the edge of Hell. Lloyd had proposed the project “Hell Express 666” to the King of Hell five months ago. This moment marked the completion of the very first railroad in Hell, which stretched 86 miles long.

“Finally... It’s done!”

“Waaah!”

“We’re free!”

“We can go home now!”

“I can slack off and worry my parents!’

“Hurray!”

The day the railroad was constructed, there was no one happier than the demons working out on the field. Did they feel proud for completing a construction that would be remembered throughout Hell’s history? Not at all.

They simply teared up in joy, moved by the sole fact that they were liberated from enslavement. They could now go back to their life as good-for-nothing bums. Of course, they didn’t forget to request a reward for their

efforts, and they selected the one-horned demon to represent them to strike a negotiation with Lloyd.

“Master Lloyd! I have something to tell you,” the one-horned demon said.

“What is it?”

“Don’t you think we worked back-breakingly hard up to this point?”

“Oh, did you?” Lloyd picked his ear.

“Yes! So, we ask to be compensated! Please give us our proper wages!”

“Not happening. Scram.” Lloyd flicked his finger.

“Thank you so much!”

Just like that, the negotiation was over. The other demons who received the news nodded in sheer admiration. They resolved in their hearts that they would be like Lloyd and become an evil employer when they had the chance to exploit other demons. Then each of them went back to their hometown. It was only then that Lloyd isolated himself and built something.

Clang! Twang! Clang!

Right after all the demons went back home, in the corner of a desolated platform on the edge of Hell, Lloyd held up the hammer and a chisel. He carved out a volcanic rock he had gotten from someplace, hammering and chiseling. The shape was simple and rough without any delicate calligraphy. He simply pounded and carved out the words he had been keeping to himself.

<This memorial stone is for all the demons who sacrificed themselves to build the Hell Express.>

It was a memorial stone that paid tribute to the demons who died during the Lava Giant’s ambush.

I think this will suffice.

Lloyd stared at the completed stone with a wistful look. He erected this only now because he was afraid to receive comments and gazes of disappointment from the demons who would judge his kind character.

Still, this puts me at ease.

Sure, they were demons. But they had died tragically while they were working for him. So, he wanted to mourn and pay tribute, at least in this manner, even if this was only to satisfy his guilt. Lloyd thought this was the least he could do for them. After he finished building the secret memorial stone, he made his way toward the Hell Castle. It was time to receive his payment for the construction from the King of Hell.

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Chapter 242: Hell Express Ticket (2)

“Master Lloyd, may I ask you one question?” It was Javier.

“Sure. Go ahead,” said Lloyd, giving him the green light.

“Why are you going alone?”

“Do you mean to the Hell Castle?”

“Yes.” Javier nodded as he darted his gaze at Lloyd, who was on Ggoming’s back. “I wonder if there is anything for me to do here all alone.”

“You bet there is. Why shouldn’t there be?” A smile spread across Lloyd’s face. “You have to protect this place while I’m away to report to the King of Hell. You never know with life. Another Lava Giant might come to raise hell like the last time. And the railroad we busted our guts to build could get destroyed. Am I wrong?”

“As I thought, is that your reason?” Javier’s eyes relaxed.

“What do you mean?”

“I was afraid you were abandoning me here.”

“The heck? Are you serious?”

“Yes,” Javier said firmly. “You are fully capable of doing so at any point in time.”

“Who do you see me as?” A frown appeared on Lloyd’s forehead.

“A sly, cheap, and petty person.”

“I see you even have… a list,” stated Lloyd.

“It’s convenient that way. Anyway...” Javier shrugged and gave a grin, which was a rare thing for him. “I will then hold down the fort here and

protect this place as you ordered. Have a safe trip.”

“Ah, yes. And if I happen to abandon you, make sure to find your way home.”

“Find my way home? How-”

“You have that.”

Lloyd pointed at the sky with a smirk. The Hell gate was still in the sky. Lloyd continued to speak.

“That thing is not going to close anyway. The cold wind blowing out of it will lower the temperature around this area, which is good for us. It means that the lava will harden faster, stabilizing the railroad and ground with it. So, I intend to keep the gate open.”

“Wait then-”

“Yes, you’re right,” Lloyd interrupted. “Why would I abandon you? If something happens, you could always cross over the Hell gate. Then you’d be able to easily escape from here. Sure, it’s going to be chilly because it’s the polar region on the other side, but a grandmaster can’t possibly die while shivering from the mere cold, right?”

“...”

“So, you can swim from there to the Frontera fiefdom. Wow, give me a round of applause.”

“...”

“Ehem,” Lloyd cleared his throat as he saw Javier say nothing.

“...”

“Sorry, I was just kidding.”

“I clearly felt your sincerity,” Javier said at last.

“Fine. You got me.”

“I also realized that your apology was a joke.”

“Tsk. You’re too needlessly sharp.”

“Thank you. Now, hurry back from your trip.”

“Okay.”

Lloyd made Ggoming take off, and he quietly flew in silence for a while. It was only when they grew fairly distant from the edge of Hell that he let out a breath of relief.

“Haah. I did it.”

Lloyd meant that he succeeded in leaving Javier and taking a lone trip to the Hell Castle.

I was worried that he’d be stubborn about going with me for safety reasons.

Surprisingly, the man didn’t insist on doing that. It was a relief, and the reason was simple. Lloyd didn’t feel like going to the Hell Castle with him.

I have to meet the King of Hell. But the king keeps calling me Suho Kim.

That made Lloyd uncomfortable and nervous. Javier wasn’t a dull person, so he’d naturally get curious about the strange nickname the king had for him.

I want to avoid that kind of situation at all costs.

At worst, his true identity could be blown. How would Javier react if that happened? How would he treat him? Lloyd wondered but couldn’t imagine it in his head. That made him even more nervous and reluctant.

Anyway, I’m glad to go see the King of Hell alone without him.

The thought lightened his heart a little. Just then, something wiggled in his chest, and there came a grumbling voice.

“Hey... No one’s around you, right? Can’t you at least let me out during these kinds of moments?”

It was Frontera who had been hiding in Lloyd’s inner pocket. Ghost Frontera was grumbling. Lloyd shook his head.

“No. You can’t.”

“Why not?!”

“I can’t be bothered.”

“What?”

“If I get you out, you’re going to get all whiny and clingy. Am I wrong?”

“Hey, t-that’s-”

“I’m right. So, I’m not letting you out. You’re noisy and pesky,” firmly said Lloyd.

“Ha. So what, you’re going to keep me locked in here, you bastard?” Its voice was high now.

“It sounds a bit wrong to say that I’m locking you. Let’s say that I’m protecting you.”

“That’s the same thing! Eek! Argh!”

Lloyd suddenly felt something tumble and scuffle inside his inner pocket, and at last, his button popped open with Ghost Frontera sticking its head out.

“Whew! Ugh. I could barely breathe inside, seriously!” said Ghost Frontera in an accusing voice.

“...”

“Bastard. There’s no need to straighten your face like that. I’m not getting out. I’ll just stick my head out like this. Is this not allowed, either? Huh?”

“Haah...” sighed Lloyd.

“I’m the one who wants to sigh, punk. Think about it. It’s been already a month since I’ve been imprisoned in your inner pocket, crushed under Ppodong or those other things.”

“Must have been warm, comfy, and fluffy.”

“Nice, my ass.”

“...”

“All I want is to get some fresh air for the first time in a month, and you won’t even let me do that? Can you still call yourself a human being?”

“Yeah. I am a human. And you’re a ghost.”

“...”

“You were about to curse, weren’t you?” asked Lloyd, already knowing what Frontera would say.

“Of course.”

“Did you stop your reflexes because you were about to insult your parents by accident?”

“Dammit. I despise you.”

“Thank you. Thank you for hating me.”

“...”

Ghost Frontera clamped its mouth shut. Lloyd, who caused it to shut its mouth, enjoyed the satisfying silence. After a long silence, Frontera opened its mouth first.

“*Hey, you fake,”* called Frontera.

“…”

“*Hey?”* It called again.

“…”

“Oh, come on. Answer me now.”

“I can’t unless you call my name,” Lloyd replied in a relaxed voice.

“*Hey, Lloyd. Happy now?”* blurted Frontera with a frown.

“Sure. What do you want?”

“It’s about how you’ll help me.”

Ghost Frontera had been watching the outside scenery with its arms propped on the opening of Lloyd’s inner pocket. When Lloyd looked down, it had a surprisingly serious and grim gaze. He realized why it decided to stick its head out by force after silently remaining in his pocket for a month. It was to discuss this topic with him.

Does Frontera think that it’s my turn to help it since my construction is over? Or is it nervous because I might leave Hell like this?

Probably both. That must be the reason why Ghost Frontera insisted on having a conversation.

“*What happened with that? You said you’d look around.”*

The question wasn’t one he welcomed. Actually, it was a hard question for him. So, Lloyd replied with feigned nonchalance, “I haven’t found anything yet.”

“What? Still?”

“Yeah.”

“Why?”

Lloyd noticed its brows slightly knitting together. He crinkled its nose as well.

Tsk. This is why I didn’t feel comfortable talking with this dude.

Lloyd felt strangely indebted to Ghost Frontera, and that was the reason why he couldn’t dismiss its whining. Lloyd was annoyed and didn’t want to deal with it. But at the same time, he was apologetic toward Frontera. And so, he didn’t know how to react.

“I just couldn’t find a way to help you. Really.” he replied with the least amount of emotion possible in his voice.

“You couldn’t find a way?”

“Yeah.”

“Really?”

“Yeah.”

“Isn’t it more like you didn’t try to find one?”

“...”

Its questions started to feel like a nail. And its interrogating questions continued to come.

“Hey, be frank with me. You don’t have any intent to help me out, right?”

“Hey, come on. It’s not like that-”

“But it’s the truth.”

“…”

“Did you even try?” accused Frontera.

Lloyd seemed slightly offended. “I’m trying to think of ways to help!”

“Liar.”

“What?” Lloyd’s frown deepened.

“You think I don’t know?” Ghost’s voice dripped with rancor. *“Thinking, my ass. You aren’t even bothering to think about this. You’ve been too preoccupied with thinking about how to construct the railroad or whatever it was the King of Hell told you to build. Am I wrong?”*

“Hey.”

“Do you think I’ve been goofing around in your pocket for the past month? I was listening and brainstorming. Can you bastard honestly say that you ever thought about helping me for even a second?”

“Hey, watch your words.” Lloyd gritted his teeth. “You think it’s easy to help you out? In all seriousness, you don’t know how I can either. Still, I’m willing to find a way for me to. Do you really think that’s going to happen in a month? Really?”

“Ha. You and your silver tongue. I hear nothing but excuses.”

“What? Excuses?”

“Yeah. Excuses.” Ghost Frontera smirked in derision. *“You think I don’t know what your plan is?”*

“My plan?”

“To stall for time by saying you’re taking care of urgent matters first. And later, apologize, saying that you just can’t find any way to help me out. Then abandon me. That’s your plan.”

“...”

“First, you steal a happy man’s life, as well as his family and everything. And now, you’re playing with the ghost. Ha. You scumbag. You’re a despicable thief.”

“Hey.”

“What? Speak up if you have something to say.”

“Don’t talk that way. What does it change?”

“Nothing. That’s why I’m doing this,” said Frontera.

“What?” Lloyd’s frown deepened.

Ghost Frontera’s smirk deepened. *“You won’t help me. I know, you bastard.”*

“Ha... Seriously. Are you going to keep treating me like a criminal?”

“Of course. Can you even make any excuses for yourself?”

“I really wasn’t going to say this, but...” Lloyd, unable to hold any longer, spoke the very thing he’d been keeping to himself. “You were destined to die a year and a half later even if you didn’t lose your body. Did you know that?”

“What?” A scowl appeared on Ghost Frontera’s face.

“The pub where you made a scene every day. You were fated to vomit blood in the corner and die there.”

“Bastard! What are you talking about?!”

“Want me to go on?”

“...”

Ghost Frontera shut its mouth while Lloyd opened his, and the latter continued to speak the words he dared not tell anyone. The downfall of the Frontera barony in the novel. The tragic end of Lloyd, his parents, and his brother Julian. Lloyd narrated the story without any emotion, and Ghost Frontera intently listened without saying anything all the while. When Lloyd finished sharing the story, Ghost Frontera burst out in bitter laughter.

“Ha! So what? You want me to believe that?”

“...”

“Fine,” Ghost Frontera went on, *“I’ll be generous, and let’s say that I do. But so what? You scumbag. You want me to bow down because you changed my family’s fate? Should I praise you? Is that what you want? Huh?”*

“Praise, my foot. I don’t have any high expectations for you,” denied Lloyd.

“Then what are you trying to say?”

“I’m just stating the truth. You’re directly involved, so you should know about it.”

Lloyd’s voice was sharp as a knife. He was getting tired of arguing with the ghost.

“Fine,” Lloyd went on, “you might be right. I am a thief. You can curse me out all you want. Even now, to be honest, I don’t know how to help you. I’m at a complete loss. But is that so wrong of me?”

“...”

“Sure, if you say that it’s wrong, then I am wrong. I’ll be the bad guy here if I don’t help you out. But do you know what’s going to happen in that case? I’ll be the bad guy but still manage to live a good life without consequences. Then what, do you want me to die then? That isn’t it, either. I can’t think of anything else for me to do. “

“...”

“I really don’t know,” Lloyd’s voice was now tired. “I tried in my own way. Look what I’ve achieved ever since I got in your body. And yet, if you keep blaming me, I really don’t know what to do anymore. Do you understand?”

“Sure, since I was going to die anyway, I should be thankful that you let my family live in exchange for taking my body, right?”

“Hey, that’s not what I mean.”

“Bullshit. To me, it’s the same thing.”

“What are you...”

Lloyd was about to refute but stopped short when he cast a glance at the ghost. Ghost Frontera was crying.

“Yeah. I was set to die anyway. But you know what? If I did die, like you said, a year and a half later, bleeding in the corner of the pub, then I’d have been able to get judged here in Hell.”

“...”

“Yeah. If I did die, then I’d have been punished in Hell. I would have been able to hope for reincarnation after enduring my time here. But look at me now. What am I? Why am I like this? I no longer belong in the outside world or the underworld. I’m just a ghost, drifting around forever without any hope of reincarnation.”

“Hey...”

“Forget it. Sorry for pathetically whining at you bastard. Just do your job and scram.”

With that, Ghost Frontera carefully made its way back into his pocket. It never stuck out its head or pleaded to be let out. Lloyd tried to talk, but it didn’t answer.

“...”

He had no clue what to say in his current situation. Lloyd simply heaved a sigh with mixed emotions. He tried to focus on flying as he silently stroked Ggoming's feathers with a nonchalant face. And soon, the uncomfortable flight came to an end as they arrived at the Hell Castle. Past the familiar entrance, he went into the king's office.

"Lloyd Frontera is honored to be in the audience of the rightful King of Hell."

Lloyd paid his respect to the King of Hell. His office hadn't changed since the last time he visited. It had a large desk chair and an even bigger work desk with a mountain of documents on top. And even the King's quick glance at him as he took care of a breathtaking amount of tasks was the same.

"Are you here? State your request before anything else."

His weary attitude from being overworked was also no different. Holding back a wry smile, Lloyd replied, "Yes, I have completed the railroad construction you assigned to me previously."

"Is that so?"

"Yes, my lord."

"As far as I know, you also took down the Lava Giant."

"Yes, I did."

"It must have been tough."

"Yes," Javier said firmly. Thank you for your acknowledgment."

"Ha. I see you aren't even trying to feign modesty?"

"For there is no need for it."

"Is that so? Anyway, I see. Thanks to you, I was able to learn quite a lot about railroad construction," said Hellkaros.

“Wait, have you been watching the whole construction?” Lloyd lifted his brow.

“Of course.”

The King of Hell put his pen and paper down. His gaze glimmered through the rimmed glasses.

“I’ve understood the basic principles. Thanks to that, I think I have gotten an idea of how we should maintain the tracks.”

“Will you be all right without separate instructions?”

“Well, I would appreciate it if you offered a more detailed explanation. Your award for it should be sufficient as well,” said Hellkaros.

“Reward?” He didn’t expect to hear that.

“You give, and you take.”

The king’s answer was so nonchalant. Lloyd secretly clenched his fists.

As expected of the King of Hell.

The king hated free charity and preferred to live by the “give and take” principle. The king continued to speak.

“Suho Kim. If you tell me how I can manage the railroad, then I will give you one pass for the Hell Express.”

“The pass to use the Hell Express, my king?” Lloyd was slightly dazed.

“Yes.” The king nodded. “If you use this pass, if you die in the future or are sentenced to Purgatory because of your sins, you will be able to use Hell Express once no matter what.”

“You mean...”

“It means you can enter the Door of Reincarnation at the edge of Hell riding the train.”

“Woah.”

Lloyd unconsciously swallowed. How could he not? He realized the true meaning of the reward, this one pass to use the train.

It’s essentially a free ticket out of Hell, isn’t it?

This meant that any evil person or a soul bound to be in pain locked up in the Purgatory of Hell could go to the edge of Hell via the train and enter the Door of Reincarnation. In other words, one-time unconditional immunity to punishment and reincarnation.

It’s... awesome.

Lloyd’s heart thumped very fast when he thought how he’d secured a good time not only when he was alive but also when he was dead. The unexpectedly better reward made his fists clench, and Lloyd was glad that he’d decided to come down here. Just then, he flinched. Something came to his mind.

“...”

Lloyd’s attitude changed. His clenched fists relaxed, and the thumping heart grew calm. And his face looked deliberative. The change in his attitude was so evident that even the King of Hell noticed and became curious.

“Suho Kim, what is wrong? Do you have an issue with my reward?”

The King of Hell cocked his head to the side, curious whether Lloyd didn’t like the Hell Express ticket. Lloyd slowly lifted his gaze, and with a contemplative look on his face, he replied, “Oh, it is not that. I have no issue with regard to your reward. However...”

“However, what?”

“I have a question.”

“What is it?”

“This thing...” Lloyd slowly took his breath, organizing his thoughts in his head. Getting rid of greed in his heart, he resolved and asked, “This ticket you are planning to give me... Can a wandering ghost reincarnate with it?”

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Chapter 243: Those Who Left, Those Who Stayed (1)

“This ticket you are planning to give me... Can a wandering ghost reincarnate if it uses this?”

“What is that?”

Lloyd’s question was unexpected. The King of Hell scowled before saying, “Indeed, it can. It can reincarnate. The pass was made to grant that privilege in the first place. But why do you ask?”

“Actually...” mumbled Lloyd before making the confession. “There is a ghost I would like to help.”

“A ghost you would like to help?” replied the King of Hell. “I wonder if it’s the one I am thinking of.”

“Do you have a guess for who it is?”

“Of course,” the King of Hell chuckled and laughed. “Suho Kim. You are about to help the ghost of Lloyd Frontera, who started to wander around Hell after you have taken your body. Is my assumption wrong?”

“No, you are right.”

Lloyd conceded without a fight. This matter required him to gain the king’s permission anyway. It wasn’t something for him to hide in the first place. He continued to speak.

“Your assumption is right. I wish to give this train ticket to the ghost.”

“Why?” asked the King of Hell with curiosity in his voice.

“Excuse me?”

“You must have a reason. You see, the ticket I am bestowing you is an extremely valuable gift. It offers the tremendous benefit of being unconditionally exempt from punishment in Hell. Even if you have

committed hundreds of unforgivable crimes, you can avoid being punished in Hell and attain a new life. I am sure you know the value of it."

"Yes, I am aware."

"And yet, you plan on giving such an incredible gift to the ghost? Why?" demanded the king.

"Because..."

Lloyd sucked in his breath and reflected on himself. Honestly, he couldn't pinpoint the reason himself. He simply followed his heart to make a decision, albeit a bit impulsively. It was a mystery to him even after he thought over his decision and reflected on himself.

"I don't know," said Lloyd at last.

"What? You do not know?" The king lifted his brow.

"Yes."

Laughter escaped Lloyd as he answered. He really didn't know the reason. But his heart was relieved when the decision was made. He wondered if he had lost his mind and just gave a chuckle instead.

"I really don't know. I just made the decision to do so. It is that simple. Ah, of course, I do think it is a waste. As you see, there are tears in my eyes." Lloyd approached closer.

"Hmm... Well..." the King of Hell observed. "You aren't lying."

"Yes, I do think I'm wasting this opportunity, and I ask myself why I am doing this. But even more strangely, I have no thoughts of changing my decision."

"Suho Kim. You are more foolish than you look."

"Yes," answered Lloyd with a sigh. "I think I am. But now, my heart is at ease due to my stupidity at the moment."

“Is that so?”

“Yes.”

It was truly a strange thing. He was giving away a tremendous gift without anything in return. Yet, his heart was light and filled with relief. And even though he said it was a wasted opportunity or whatever, truthfully speaking, he didn’t feel that way.

Tsk. It’s not because that hooligan Frontera made me weak, or because I feel guilty. I’m doing this because I’m tired of its whining. It is beyond annoying to hear Frontera whining, insisting, and begging for me to take responsibility and help out.

Lloyd thought this was an opportunity for him to get rid of one less burden of his. It was the cost of getting rid of this pesky burden. This was an investment. So, he concluded that he wasn’t being a fool. He was doing this for Arcos and Marbella Frontera. Lloyd reiterated these thoughts in his head and pulled himself together.

A bitter smile appeared on the King of Hell’s face. But his eyes grew soft.

Suho Kim.

The king concluded that Lloyd was a sly but not an evil person. His sly character was merely a result of trying to survive in extreme poverty.

I want him.

Lloyd was normally a stout-hearted man. However, in critical moments, he didn’t lose the humanity in him while also making sure to receive his proper dues. And so, the more the king saw of Lloyd, the more he wanted him.

This human. If he dies and ends up in Hell, I might as well just hire him and put him to work.

It looked like he wouldn’t need to share much of his authority with Lloyd. It seemed giving him discretionary power to act freely on his own would be enough. Delegating him that kind of power alone would...

He’d work the Knights and demons to death, just like he did while constructing the railroad.

The King of Hell was impressed with how Lloyd put 30,000 demons to work and wondered if this was what it felt like to be a grandfather who had a clever grandchild.

I will make you work under me once you die.

The King of Hell resolved his plan to scout Lloyd in the future and bent over before he spoke.

“Suho Kim. Are you really going to give up your Hell Express ticket for reincarnation to Ghost Frontera?”

“Yes, I will, my lord,” said Lloyd without any second of hesitation.

“Good. I think highly of your decision.”

“Thank you.”

“Do not be.”

The King of Hell smiled with a glow of satisfaction. Lloyd didn’t need the reincarnation ticket anyway since he would be mindlessly working next to him later on. Hiding his true motive, the king held out a piece of paper to Lloyd, the man in charge of the future in Hell.

“This pass bears my signature. Present it, and no one in Hell will ever stop you at the Door of Reincarnation,” instructed the King of Hell.

“Thank you.”

“Then, can the train be operated now?” asked the King of Hell.

“Oh, I just have to run a final test drive.”

“A test drive? Get it done quickly. I wish to get off work for the first time in 670,000 years.”

“Yes, my king.”

After paying his respect to the king, Lloyd removed himself from the office and headed to the Hell Express station at the Hell Castle. A prototype train, which was created for the test run, was there.

Woah. They built this better than I expected.

Lloyd had separately ordered the construction of the train while he focused on the construction of the railroad. Its structure was very primitive and simple. The massive carts that the demons used were connected in one line and their wheels were modified to fit the rails. Then bones and tarps were laid on top to protect everything from volcanic ash and flame sparks.

The train even utilized a manual engine. It moved by having eight demons at the very front car industriously pressing its lever and generating power through the pulley. And when the demons grew tired, another eight on standby would take their place.

So, the train adopted a bionic and eco-friendly power generation method, utilizing a total of 24 demons that were grouped by eight. That was the stateliness of the Hell Express. In other words, the Hell Express existed for the sole purpose of transporting souls to the edge of Hell.

“Don’t expect a comfortable ride from this.”

“…”

Inside the modified cabin that used to be a giant cart, Lloyd sank down on the floor and grinned. He was staring at the ghost of Frontera sitting across from him. It was back to its original size. But the latter wasn’t speaking.

“Seriously? Are you still sulking?” Lloyd lifted his brow.

“…”

“What? Why? What? Don’t look at me like that. Speak.”

“…”

Ghost Frontera didn’t speak. But its gaze at Lloyd was distinctly different from a while ago. There wasn’t anger, resentment, frustration, or any of the negative emotions that played across its eyes as it blew off steam at Lloyd.

The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose slightly. “Hey, you’re grateful but embarrassed for getting angry at me earlier, right?”

“...”

“I can see you flinching in guilt.”

“Oh, tsk... Come on.”

“If you’re thankful, just say it. Don’t curse me out.”

“Who says I’m grateful?” snapped Ghost Frontera.

“Really?”

“Of course. Grateful for what? You surprised me.”

“Ha,” Lloyd heaved lightly. “I guess I really took you by surprise.”

“How can I not, you bastard? You just did something unthinkable and-”

“Touched your heart?” put in Lloyd with a smirk.

“Touched, my ass.”

“More like your personality is ass.”

“So what? You got a problem with that?”

“No, I’m relieved. I won’t have to see you anymore.”

“The feeling is mutual, scumbag.”

“So, are you happy?”

“Of course.

Ghost Frontera chuckled. Lloyd put on the same smile. Meanwhile, the train started to run for the first time, a test run that would be remembered throughout Hell’s history.

Thump! Clunk! Clank! Thump! The cabin shook terribly. There was a blaring din and vibration that hurt his buttocks. But Lloyd didn’t feel too uncomfortable since the feeling was familiar to him.

Well, this is similar to the army truck I used to ride in the military.

The rattling that felt like it was about to break his pelvis. The chaotic ringing noise. This train ride was as comfortable as the truck used in the military, which made the men in uniform feel like loads of cartons. Putting on a relaxed smile, Lloyd stared at Ghost Frontera.

“Hey, tell me if you feel motion sick.”

“Why?”

“I’ll remove the tarp. That way, you can stick your head out and vomit.”

“I might as well just kick you out of the tarp,” growled Ghost Frontera.

“Did you forget already how I beat you up after you tried to do that?”

“No, I didn’t, bastard,” huffed Ghost Frontera.

“Then let’s just go reincarnate like a good boy. Anyway, how do you feel? What does it feel like to be the passenger of this monumental train?”

“Well, nothing much.” Ghost Frontera roughly scratched its jaw. *“I want to get a drink. It’s been a while.”*

“A drink?” repeated Lloyd.

“Yeah.”

“Have you not been drinking?”

“Of course. How do you expect me to drink when I’m like this?”

“Well, you have a point.”

A chuckle escaped because it looked like he had just asked a silly question. Ghost Frontera did the same and chuckled.

“Then let me ask you a question as well.”

“What is it?”

“You came from another world, right?”

“Uh-huh. You knew?”

“Of course. I stuck to your side for over a year to get my body back. How could I not?”

“Well, it does make sense now that you mention it.”

“Do you have any unfinished business in your world?”

“Nothing really.”

“You’re a heartless bastard. Don’t you miss your family back there?”

“No. My parents all passed away.”

Ghost Frontera paused for a second before saying, *“They say your family is always with you as long as they’re in your heart. Cheer up, scumbag.”*

“What are you saying?” Lloyd frowned with a smile.

“Forget it. What about my parents? Are they well?”

“Of course. They are as healthy as a horse.”

“Really?”

“Yeah.” Lloyd stared at Ghost Frontera. Then he continued in honesty, “Come to think of it, I’m relaying this news late. The Frontera family is no longer a barony.”

“What? What do you mean?”

“It’s a county now.”

“Whaaat?” Ghost Frontera’s eyes widened.

“Surprising, right? I’m surprised, too. Anyway, the count has resumed his hobby recently too.”

“Wood carving?”

“Uh-huh. There are a bunch of wooden sculptures in the study already.”

“Then what about Mother’s garden?”

“It’s still there. Oh, it has doubled in size. But I’m slightly worried about the count’s back and knees.”

“What’s up with that old man’s back and knees?”

“He’s helping out with the gardening. He insists on crouching and giving a hand when he’s not used to the work.”

“Tsk. I guess the man is still senseless as always.”

“Aren’t you going to ask about Julian?”

“Don’t have to. He’s a smart kid, so I’m sure he’s doing well on his own.”

“Correct. He recently got married.”

Cough!

“I’m serious,” Lloyd stressed when he saw doubt flash across Ghost Frontera’s face.

“Really?”

“Yeah.”

“With whom?”

“The daughter of a sultan in the east. She’s a high-level sword expert, so she’s really good at fighting. It would be quite a sight if they got into a fight.”

“Julian will be beaten to death.”

“Probably?”

“...”

Lloyd and Ghost Frontera. The two paid tribute to Julian for a second as they imagined Julian having an imaginary quarrel with his wife. And then they both burst into a chuckle at the same time.

“So, what do you want to be reincarnated as?”

“Me?”

“Yeah.”

“I don’t know. This is all too sudden. Well, if I have to choose...”

“What?”

“A whale.”

“A whale?”

“Yeah. A whale.” Ghost Frontera nodded. *“I’ve spent far too much time in Hell, and it’s flipping hot here. So, I want to be plunged in cold water.”*

“Then you don’t have to be a whale. You could be a sardine. Or an anchovy,” pointed Lloyd.

“Those are easy to hunt and kill, you little jerk.”

“Oh, is that so?”

“Obviously. Anyway, I just wish to live freely. So, I’d hate to be born as a human again. I think it’d be stifling.”

“I guess you won’t be able to have your beloved drinks if you’re born as a whale.”

“Oh, tsk. Come on. You better be ready if I am reincarnated as a dragon.”

“Even if that happens, I’ll be dead from old age by the time you are fully grown.”

“...”

“Heh.”

“Haah. This bastard, seriously.”

“Seriously what?”

“Thank you for keeping your promise, bastard.”

“Aren’t your words a bit late,” Lloyd threw a snide remark.

“Who cares?”

They laughed again. In a terribly rattling train, against the backdrop of a slowly passing Hell scenery, Lloyd and Ghost Frontera both laughed. And Lloyd felt a part of his heart growing lighter.

A burdensome weight he didn’t know he was carrying started to grow light. The weight was guilt. The crime of pushing away Frontera from his own body, no matter how unintentional it was. The guilt of hiding the truth and

parading around as the real Lloyd. He had even felt like a cuckoo bird inside a nest it didn't belong to until then.

"So, I will take good care of the count and countess. I'm sorry."

"Forget it, you bastard."

"And I plan on revealing the truth in the future. That is, about you and me."

"I said I get it, bastard."

"Whew, sorry. I just felt weird all of a sudden."

"Ha." Lloyd smiled bitterly while Ghost Frontera smiled and blinked back the tears. The latter thought Lloyd might as well not make it cry if he was apologetic. The train slowly rattled its way, and beside the adjoining car was Javier, the knight of the Frontera family, quietly listening to Lloyd and Frontera's conversation.

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Chapter 244: Those Who Left, Those Who Stayed (2)

Clunk... Clunk... The train leisurely clunked its way along the rail, and the outside scenery passed by at a slow pace. Inside one of the cars, Javier, the knight of the Frontera County, was sitting with his arms folded against his chest. With his head down, he bit his lips. But his gaze wasn’t darted toward the ground.

He was intently staring at the side wall, where the voices of two people were coming from. Voices kept coming. Extremely familiar voices. Both belonged to Lloyd Frontera. And as Javier heard them, he was able to realize something, at last. The question he had asked at times but never mentioned aloud. The curiosity that constantly surged in him but he never spoke aloud of. And even the suspicions that shot through him, which he chose to bottle down. But now, he knew. He had the answer to everything.

The real and the fake.

The victim and the thief.

The self-indulgent and the hardworking.

The degenerate and the constructive.

The despicable and the respectable.

Javier finally understood that they were two different individuals, and no one else was aware of it. He was enlightened at last.

Master Lloyd.

Javier bit his lips until they were white. Yet, he had no idea which Lloyd he just inwardly called. He was truly lost about it. Was it the real Lloyd Frontera who lived as a hooligan? Or the fake Lloyd Frontera who lifted his family from misery with hard work and dedication? Javier was absolutely unsure which one he called for, served, and wished to stay beside. He was filled with anguish.

Should he slash down on him instead? Make the fake Lloyd pay for his sins? In principle, that seemed to be the right choice. A deathly desire flashed across Javier's eyes for a split second. But soon enough, it disappeared much more quickly than it appeared. He shook his head hard.

No.

That didn't seem like the right judgment in any case. Was it because he liked the fake version of Lloyd Frontera? No. He wasn't foolish enough to involve his personal feelings in a matter like this. Currently, he was judging the new situation at hand based on one criterion.

Count Arcos Frontera, the very person Javier had pledged his lifelong allegiance to. Javier considered how his decision would affect and harm his lord. He wondered which choice would be in the best interest for him. That was the only criteria with which he strove to judge this situation. He coldly evaluated the situation, excluding most of his emotions in the process. And the cold nature of his evaluation made his decision all the more painful.

Please forgive me, Master Lloyd.

Javier made up his mind to give up Ghost Frontera and spare the fake Lloyd. It was an inevitable choice. It appeared so as he heard the conversation between the two Lloyds.

It appears the real Lloyd has become a ghost.

He figured that his former young master was as good as dead. It seemed that any attempt to retrieve his body would be useless. In other words, there was no way for the real Lloyd, the hooligan, to be brought back to life. What would happen if he killed the fake Lloyd now as punishment? It would only lead to terrible results.

The situation won't get any better. No, it'll get even worse.

Whatever the truth was, whoever had taken over Lloyd's body, the fake one had been acting as the real one in the most confident and natural manner up to this point. No, he had behaved in an incomparably exemplary manner

and saved the family from the pit of destruction. So, killing the fake young master wouldn’t do any good for the family. It would be like losing a giant pillar holding up an entire building. Javier knew that without the fake Lloyd, his lord’s family would be back on the track of destruction.

This is the only way.

It really was the case, realistically. Who was the one that received the trust from Queen Magentano? Technically speaking, it wasn’t Count Frontera, his lord, but Lloyd, the fake. And who had billed the Lacona viscounty for water? And who was maintaining their water system? That would also be the fake young master. And what about Bibeong, who stops monsters from the opposite side of the eastern mountain range from invading his fiefdom? Bibeong, too, was a fantastical creature under the command of the fake Lloyd.

On top of everything, the fiefdom’s ondol and coal mine, the maintenance and repair of the apartment complex for the refugees, and Dragon Solitas in charge of treating the sludge... Fake Lloyd was at the center of countless businesses and projects. What then would happen if the fake Lloyd disappeared? Nothing in the Frontera fiefdom would function properly.

“...”

It was impossible for him not to admit it at this point. Even though the living Lloyd was evidently a sham, he was better than the real one. No, he had become an indispensable figure in the fiefdom. Javier loosened his grip on his sword. Of course, this conclusion didn’t settle all of his concerns and distress. There was still a big concern left in his mind.

Should I then report this to the lord?

The decision he made here wasn’t final, and it definitely wasn’t definitive. It was only a temporary judgment on whether he should kill the fake Lloyd right now. The final decision, however, had to be made by Count Frontera. And so, Javier was on the fence.

It is clearly proper for me to inform the lord right away.

But somehow, he didn’t feel like doing so. Though keeping it under his hat could be a form of betrayal and he was aware of this with absolute certainty, Javier was hesitant about telling the truth. But he couldn’t understand why. The answer soon came to him when he could hear the two Lloyds’ conversing once again.

“So, I will take good care of the count and countess. I’m sorry.”

“Forget it, bastard.”

“And I plan on revealing the truth in the future. That is, about you and me.”

“...”

Once again, Javier bit his lips. And he wondered what the imposter was planning with those words. Why in the world was he speaking that way while making Javier’s heart soften?

Is it right to give him a chance... for now?

Javier felt the sincerity in the fake Lloyd’s remarks. It could be a lie, but Javier wanted to trust the former. He wanted to trust that the fake Lloyd felt genuine guilt toward Count Arcos and Count Marbella and would come clean someday. So, it was only right for Javier to wait.

“...”

Javier wondered to himself if he had lost it. He suppressed the thought that crossed his mind for a second. At least the fake young master didn’t turn a blind eye to the real one. The former gave a helping hand to the real Lloyd, who had become a wandering ghost. The former had the decency to be apologetic and take responsibility for his wrongdoings. So, Javier thought that he should wait and observe. At the very least, it was only right to give a chance for the person directly involved in the situation to reveal the truth.

I am sorry, my lord.

Javier closed his eyes, hoping that his judgment would not harm the Frontera family. He struggled to suppress the confusion and dismay surging

inside his heart. Amid his internal conflict, the train dutifully moved forward with a dull sound. It traveled consistently, slowly, and efficiently until it arrived on the platform at the edge of Hell, the final station.

“Whew.”

Lloyd got down from the train, and he massaged his butt. Just like he expected, the train ride was similar to his experience on the army truck, but he couldn’t bring himself to feel nostalgic about it. His butt was quite sore, and even his back ached.

In other words, this is a hellish train ride.

Lloyd smiled wryly, telling himself that this was good enough since the train was constructed for the purpose of transporting souls in the first place. Moreover, the comfort of the ride wasn’t what mattered. There was something significantly more important that required more of his care.

Javier couldn’t be nearby here, right?

Lloyd carefully looked around the moment he got down from the platform, fearing Javier would be near and see the ghost of Frontera. He prudently surveyed the surrounding area, his heart beating much like the time he stole some money from his mother’s purse. After much surveillance, he was put at ease.

Looks like he isn’t here.

Lloyd had instructed Javier to guard this area when he headed to Hell Castle to report to the King of Hell. Could it be that he had gone to the bathroom? Or was he taking a nap after growing tired of waiting? Whatever the reason was, Lloyd felt a rush of relief when Javier was nowhere to be found in the vast, open area of the station.

Now is my chance.

Javier could come back if he dawdled around. The situation would get complicated if Javier saw Ghost Frontera. In the worst-case scenario, he

might see Lloyd as a criminal and attack him. Lloyd wiped the sweat off his forehead and hurried Ghost Frontera.

“Hey, hurry up and get out. Quickly,” urged Lloyd.

“Oh, tsk. Stop pushing me.”

“I’m not pushing you. I’m just asking you to move quickly.”

“What, you telling me to reincarnate fast now that your business with me is over?” grumbled Ghost Frontera.

“Come on! It’s not that.”

“What a coward. Are you scared that Javier might find out?”

“Haah. You are right.”

“Fine. Let’s hurry. I never liked that jerk anyway. I don’t want to bump into him.”

“You don’t like him?”

“No.” Ghost Frontera nodded at Lloyd’s question. And in the most obvious tone, Ghost Frontera retorted, *“It’s not fair for a human to look like that. I hate him. I feel like life is cheating me whenever I see him, and it pisses me off. I’ve been in a bad mood ever since my father put that bastard on my side to guard me.”*

“You too...?” Lloyd gaped as though he just met a comrade.

“Me too,” seconded Ghost Frontera wistfully.

“Dammit.”

For a second, a sense of camaraderie swelled in their hearts as the two berated the good-looking guys. And then they hurried up again toward the Door of Reincarnation that stood at the end of the platform. This location

was chosen by design to ensure that the transported souls could enter the door through the platform as soon as they got off the train.

“Whew.”

Could it be that Ghost Frontera was jittery to stand in front of the door? Or was its heart getting the flutters in its stomach as it was about to say goodbye to its wandering life? Ghost Frontera collected its breath for a while before turning Lloyd’s way and chuckling.

“I’ll be going then.”

“Okay.”

They didn’t exchange any special goodbyes or touching words of farewell. No, in the first place, there wasn’t a need for any of it. Ghost Frontera and Lloyd knew this very well. So, they just waved their hands at each other, much like a couple parting ways at night after spending a relaxed day together and knowing they’d meet each other again the following day despite their half-hearted goodbye. Similarly, the two bid each other farewell without making a fuss in an ordinary manner. But before the final step into the Door of Reincarnation, Ghost Frontera turned and looked in Lloyd's way.

“…”

Its lips trembled very softly as though it was whispering. Lloyd couldn’t make out its words. That was it. Ghost Frontera was gone.

“…”

Lloyd gawked at the door. For some reason, his heart was perturbed. Words fell short of describing the feeling. So he just gave a soft sigh and turned, trudging back to the train and hopping onboard. And he collapsed to the ground that was rattling and stared at the area opposite of him.

It was the spot chatty Ghost Frontera had sat a moment ago. But now, only the tarp was fluttering against the wind. And the train started to move,

clunking much like a while ago at a slow and consistent pace. The scenery of Hell moved just the same, and all the while, Lloyd didn’t say anything. He remained seated still and thought to himself that Hell wasn’t a good place. The air was hot, and the volcanic ash stung his eyes. Lloyd rubbed his eyes several times with his sleeve. Later, once the long journey to the Hell Castle came to an end, Lloyd got down to be welcomed by someone he was glad to see.

“Eh...? Javier?”

“Did you arrive just now, Master Lloyd.”

“What are you doing here?” asked Lloyd, feeling dazed to find Javier here. He had told the latter to stay at the other station. So what was he doing here?

While Lloyd remained confused, Javier smiled and said, “I came here because I was nervous.”

“Nervous?”

“Yes.”

“About what?”

“About you abandoning me for good,” said Javier, “That is why I ran all the way here until I discovered that you went to check on the train.”

“So, have you been waiting until I got here?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.”

“Ha... You must have not liked the idea of swimming from the polar region to the Frontera fiefdom.”

“I did not,” Javier said as he nodded. “I was against it, but now that I am seeing you here, I am starting to change my mind.”

“Change your mind? How?”

“That I’d rather avoid seeing your face in any case.”

“...”

“It was a joke.”

“No, you sounded pretty serious.”

“Did you see through me?”

“Probably?” Lloyd scoffed.

Lloyd was relieved. Javier had done something unilaterally, so he couldn’t have seen the ghost of Frontera at the edge of Hell. The latter had come to escort, which forced Lloyd to feign a forced smile and exchange a silly joke. It was a relief, truly.

“Then let’s go. I have to give the report about the result of the test to the king.”

“Understood.”

Lloyd walked ahead of Javier, his heart slightly lighter than a second ago. Javier started at the back of Lloyd with a meaningful gaze.

“...”

Javier was relieved that Lloyd bought his hasty lie, so he was able to treat him like usual and exchange silly banter with him. He was truly glad that he could turn a blind eye to the eyes of fake Lloyd, which were slightly swollen.

Master Lloyd. May you have a peaceful and happy new life.

Javier prayed from the bottom of his heart. The real and the fake. The victim and the thief. The self-indulgent and the hardworking. The former master and the present master. He wished that both of them would have a peaceful and happy future and that every day left in their lives will be

peaceful and warm. The one who left and the one who stayed. Javier prayed in his heart for both of them. And without a word, he followed Lloyd.

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Chapter 245: For the Dragon King's Support (1)

After a preparation period of one month and four months of construction, it all resulted in the first-ever railroad in Hell. The report on Hell Express 666 was stellar.

"So, there were no issues during the test drive?" asked the King of Hell.

"Yes, my lord."

Lloyd had entered the Hell Castle a while ago after finishing the test run and politely knelt down before the king.

"After inspecting the overall operation for the last time, the average speed of the train on a stable drive was about 21 mph. Therefore, it will take about seven hours for a train to transport the souls from here to the edge of Hell.

"Seven hours, huh," mused Hellkaros.

"That includes the time it takes to load and unload all the souls."

"Good," replied Hellkaros with a smile. "Then I can construct more of the trains you tested today."

"That is right, my lord," said Lloyd, "Moreover, I constructed the drains so the lava will seep out around the bed without overflowing and damaging the tracks."

"A drain, I see."

"From now on, the remaining demons should be placed in even intervals to carefully observe the amount of lava flowing nearby, check for clogged drains, and study the state of the tracks."

"Then they can conduct repairs when a problem arises?" asked the king.

"Indeed."

“Hmm, then what if something unmanageable occurs?”

“...”

“Can I summon you then?” suggested the king.

Instead of answering right away, Lloyd looked up at the King of Hell, feeling slightly bitter. If only he could, Lloyd wanted to grab the king by his collar and shout, “You are an awful client!” for asking whether he would travel down here again to conduct a repair. But Lloyd decided to opt for a more constructive method to make the most out of this situation.

Plastering a salesman's smile on his face, Lloyd said, “Of course, but with a fee.”

“You are heartless,” blurted the king.

“We did not have an agreement on free follow-up maintenance when we signed the contract. Plus, you do not enjoy receiving free services,” pointed Lloyd.

“Hmm. You are right, yet...”

“As long as you offer sufficient compensation, I will answer your calling.”

“Sufficient compensation, huh.”

“Yes.”

“Are you suggesting that what’s considered sufficient will differ based on the situation at hand?”

Lloyd didn’t answer on purpose.

“You are,” said the king, getting his message.

“It cannot be helped as our circumstances and market prices fluctuate every day.”

Lloyd didn’t deny the king’s comment as it was unnecessary. He simply laughed it off without shame, but it wasn’t to dismiss the king’s request. It was his desperate effort to prevent receiving any unreasonable demands or calls from him.

Obviously! What would happen if I agreed to repair the track in advance? That king would call me anytime he wants or needs me!

Lloyd could already envision it in his head. The king would call him for simple repairs involving bad tracks, a clunky train, overflows of mana, or unstable beds. It was obvious that the king would summon Lloyd for tasks that he could solve on his own by examining the issue and putting the demons to work for a bit.

Why would he still call me then? Because that’s convenient for him!

What would happen if Lloyd provided the after-service once, twice, and so on? What would happen if his continued favors became the norm? He’d eventually become an official pushover, the kind that responds to every summon. That would be how the king viewed him. Lloyd wished to prevent that from happening.

Of course. I’ll be busy enjoying a comfortable and relaxing life in retirement. Why should I take a business trip to Hell?

He had been able to exonerate himself from being a mindless construction robot for the queen after the longest time. If he wasn’t careful, he was at risk of becoming one in Hell. Sensing the impending crisis, Lloyd made a frantic effort.

“That’s why I apologize, but I cannot be readily available to come here at any time. I have other work to do,” said Lloyd.

“You mean I would need to compensate you for coming down here despite your busy schedule?”

“Yes.”

“But then it will be your choice to decide whether you will come down here based on the compensation I offer. Am I right?”

“I apologize again, but that is right.”

“Hmm.”

The King of Hell sent a meaningful gaze, and Lloyd endeavored to keep smiling as he felt a pang of guilt in his heart.

Wait a second. The king isn’t going to sentence me to life imprisonment in Hell in the future just because he’s offended or anything, right? That can’t possibly be his decision.

Of course, it was not. It was impossible. The king was the fairest man in Hell who only made rational judgments without letting his personal feelings get in the way. That quality of the king was what Lloyd banked on while exhibiting such shameless behavior. Soon, Lloyd’s gamble was proven to be a success.

“Good. Although a part of me finds you despicable, it looks like the one who is holding all the cards in this matter is you, Suho Kim.”

“Thank you for seeing it that way...”

Lloyd sighed in relief. Thankfully, it worked, and Lloyd was able to be saved from being summoned to Hell for continuous maintenance. He could now turn down repair requests without worry. And so, Lloyd was able to receive his payment with a heart full of satisfaction.

“Now, it is time for me to pay you for the construction. Let me check the terms and agreements in the contract. Let’s see,” the King of Hell said before reading the contract. “It was to release the soul of Dragon Anticus locked up in Hell.”

“Yes, it was,” agreed Lloyd.

“Good. I will give you your compensation right away.”

Hellkaros swished his pen a few times, and he held out a paper at a demon, which hurried off with the paper. When it returned, it held a fist-sized half-opaque marble in its hand. The King of Hell handed the marble to Lloyd.

“Here. Take this.”

“Could this be the soul of Anticus?”

“To be more exact, it is a plate that temporarily holds the soul of the dragon,” explained the king.

When Lloyd peered into the marble, he did see something slightly move inside. Lloyd figured it was the soul of Anticus.

“The moment you put your mana into the marble, you will be able to release the soul right away,” the King of Hell further explained. “You would be freeing it once and for all. But do not think of doing that here. If you do, the soul will become trapped in Hell again.”

“You mean I should open the lid when I get home, so to say.”

“Indeed.”

“I see. Thank you.”

Lloyd took the soul-containing marble with care and put it in his backpack. And then, he suddenly looked up at the king. The question that had been taking up a corner of his heart but which he never dared show came to his mind.

“Oh, excuse me. Can I ask you something?”

“What is it?”

“Do you know why I possessed the body of Lloyd Frontera?”

All these times, from the very start to this moment, Lloyd wanted to know. He was curious. But the King of Hell shook his head as soon as the question was uttered.

“No, I do not know.”

“Is that so...”

“However, I can only tell you that this is a rare occurrence that happens once every hundreds of years.”

“Do you mean the way my soul crossed into another world?”

“Yes. The dimensions are not completely separate from each other after all. Though they appear distant, they’re able to influence one another due to the giant halo that envelops them.”

“Oh, yes...”

“I presume that the interruption of the gravity force that took place between the halo of dimension was affected by a fluctuation of mana. Much like how energy-filled particles from the sea of Dirac trigger the process of pair production.”

“Oh, yes, yes...”

“Do you comprehend what I am saying?”

“Please forgive me...” said Lloyd in almost a whisper.

“Tsk.”

Lloyd wondered why he was feeling guilty.

The King of Hell smiled bitterly. “But Suho Kim, you are not asking about something that someone else in your place would easily want to know.”

“My king?” asked Lloyd, taken back. “What could you mean?”

“I am talking about your body in your original world.”

“...”

Lloyd shut his mouth. He was curious, sure, but...

“I am curious,” Lloyd replied. “But I do not really want to find out.”

“Why is that?”

“It will not affect me in any way even if I found out.”

Lloyd’s smile turned bitter. It was true. Sure, he was curious, but he didn’t want to know. Nothing was going to change now, even if he did. It’d only satisfy his curiosity and nothing else. No, to be really honest, he was reluctant.

I’ve had enough of my past.

His memories of the past were overshadowed by the immense hardship he faced, no matter how hard he tried to romanticize them. So, some intermittent recollection of his past was enough. He didn’t need to go the extra mile and find out what happened to his body in his world. And besides, he never wanted to go back. Could it be that the King of Hell noticed his feelings? The king gave a chuckle.

“Is that so? I see.”

“Thank you. I just need to know if my body is alive.”

“It is alive. Happy?”

“Yes,” Lloyd replied, “That is enough.”

Lloyd didn’t necessarily want to learn in detail how his body was doing when his soul crossed into this world. It was enough to know that it was doing well.

“I suppose it is time for you to leave,” said the king, “I will then open the Hell gate for you to arrive where you left to come here.”

“Do you mean the Termina Garden in the Magenta capital?”

“Yes.”

Bzzt! At one simple gesture of the king, the Hell gate opened up at once. Through the gate, Lloyd saw a glimpse of the dim night of the garden, which was still a mess.

“Time moves differently in this world with the human world. Your five months here is only about five days in the human world,” explained the king. “Do go back now.”

“Thank you, my king.”

A sense of relief rushed through Lloyd. He was afraid that he would need to use the Hell gate that led to the polar region, the one he had opened up to beat the Lava Giant. However, thanks to the kindness of the King of Hell, he was saved from venturing through the polar region.

“Then I shall prepare a few things and go back right away.”

Lloyd hurried, telling himself that he must return before the king changed his mind. After giving a deep bow, he moved and brought Javier, fantastical creatures, and the Bone Dragon, all awaiting outside Hell Castle. Then they all passed the Hell gate. Lloyd stepped in first with his fantastical creatures. Next was Javier, followed by the Bone Dragon, who took apart its joints. Once they crossed inside, they were welcomed back with the night breeze of the human world.

“Whew...”

It was cold. Though it wasn’t winter, the brush of the ordinary wind chilled his skin as he was used to the heat from Hell. But he didn’t have the time to revel in the fresh air and grass on the ground as he had to immediately scan the surroundings as soon as the gate closed. To his relief, it was late at night. No one was around.

Lloyd called, “Draggy?”

Clack!

The Bone Dragon, or Draggy, responded in its dissembled state.

Lloyd said, “Since people will panic if they find out about you here, hide somewhere. Over there. That’s east.”

Creak!

“Keep flying, and you’ll see a giant mountain range. That’s called the eastern mountain range. Hang around there for a while. Be friendly with the orcs if you bump into them.”

Creak?

“Good boy. If you behave, I’ll introduce you to your friends in the Skeleton Corps. Okay, off you go.”

Creak!

Dragonny gave a firm answer and flew toward the east, and it was only when it was gone that Lloyd was relieved.

“Whew.”

That was when the fresh wind of the human world finally felt real to him. He had spent almost five months in Hell, but that was only five days in this world. That comforted Lloyd a little.

I’ll turn 30 next year. Haah...

But that was delayed by a few months, thanks to the different rates of time in the two worlds. The catastrophe of becoming 30 had been delayed by a few months. Moreover, he had returned from Hell, safe and unharmed.

Now, it’s time to claim my rewards.

He hadn’t taken a trip down to Hell for no reason. There was something he could gain from it. An undeniably beneficial reward. That was the sole reason for his travel. And the time had come now to receive his award for traveling to Hell.

I’ve got lots of mess to clean up. Like the garden showcase that ended up in a disaster because of the Bone Dragon. Or saving the face of the queen. But I’ll push those issues aside for now since it’s not related to me.

If he did, it would just be unnecessary meddling on his part. He could offer his help when he had the time and resources. The job belonged to the queen and the palace. So, Lloyd resolved to prioritize himself.

“Okay, let’s go first,” said Lloyd.

“Where are we going?”

Javier seemed joyful to be back from Hell. He looked bright and happy as he took in fresh air.

“Somewhere dim and shady.”

“...”

“Somewhere inconspicuous. We should release the soul of the dragon.”

That was the only way to attain membership for the Dragon King’s support. It was the most important task, something that had to be done as long as they were alive even if the world collapsed.

Lloyd hurried his steps, slipping out of the still-messy Termina Garden. Then he and Javier passed the city district and the Llojavi suspension bridge, jumping over the wall of the capital with ease into the remote, unpopulated woods. He soon settled in an appropriately vacant lot.

“No one’s around, right?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes. Aside from the twelve rabbits, one fox who has her eyes on one of them, two owls, and other small animals, no one is here,” Javier reeled off.

“Good.”

Since Javier was a grandmaster, he could be trusted. With his confirmation, Lloyd brought the marble out of his pocket and activated the Asrahan Core

Technique. Then he inserted his amplified mana into the marble.

Fwoosh! A flash appeared in the half-opaque marble. With that, the creature coiled up inside opened its eyes, and rushed out of the marble. And without giving any time for Lloyd to say anything, it shot up like a shooting star into the night sky. And then, with one more flash, it became a star in the Milky Way and disappeared.

Whoosh. The flurry of cold wind blew to dishevel his hair. Lloyd waited for a second, rolling his eyes and glancing at the sky where the ancient dragon just flew up and back at the empty marble in his hand. He found himself gulping.

It can't be.

Did that dragon do a bunk without a word of gratitude or the provision of the promised reward?

No way. No.

The dragon had made a vow that its soul would vanish if it failed to fulfill its promise. However, he wondered if the dragon still ran away and broke their promise as soon as it was freed.

But... this is concerning...

There weren't any words of appreciation or a cheesy, grandiose celebration for him. With one big flash, the dragon disappeared into the sky. Now, Lloyd was left with nothing but the cool breeze blowing at him. He couldn't help but feel anxious, wondering if this was what it felt like to be scammed by a second-hand dealer.

"Master Lloyd." Right when Lloyd was about to entertain those thoughts, he heard Javier call him with two taps on his shoulder.

"It looks like we have an unexpected guest."

A guest?

Lloyd wondered what Javier could mean. The latter said back there that no one was around. So, how did this guest get here? Lloyd turned to the side Javier was pointing at. Then he found out. There really was an unexpected visitor. He was...

The Dragon King?

Goggled-eyed, Lloyd stared at the Dragon King.

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Chapter 246: For the Dragon King’s Support (2)

The dragon king?

Lloyd’s eyes widened when he saw the figure. He was sure. There was no one around up until a moment ago. Javier had verified that himself. But now, someone was here. No, not someone. It was an animal. To be more exact, it was a lion larger than an elephant. And its claws, which were revealed between its front paws, looked menacing. Its magnificent mane gave off a majestic atmosphere, and it had bat wings and scorpion tails. But contrary to all, its belly was so chubby that Lloyd wanted to give it a touch to its fluffy and comfy texture. Anyway, based on its physical features, this creature could only be...

The manticore?

As soon as Lloyd uttered the name of the monster that emerged in front of him, the manticore opened its mouth and said, “Corong?”

“...”

“Cororong! Corong!”

“...”

Lloyd wondered what this monster was saying. Wait, could it be that it was growling? Or was it trying to start a conversation? Nonetheless, Lloyd didn’t show any outward reaction to the manticore’s roaring or greeting. He neither flinched in fear nor took a step back. His face didn’t show any hint of surprise or dismay. However, deep inside, he was flustered. But he repressed his emotions, determined to reveal nothing, controlled his facial expression, and tensed his muscles. The rationale behind his forced nonchalance was simple.

You never know with life. What if this manticore turns out to be Dragon King Verkis?

Such a thought crossed his mind, and he thought it was very likely.

Dragons can perform powerful magic. It's said that they can even morph into other races.

What this meant was that dragons were capable of shapeshifting into monsters as well. That was why Lloyd couldn't rashly show any reaction.

Duh! What if Dragon King Verkis came here with that appearance because of some weird kink of his? Shouting my dismay out loud or reacting with shock will kill my chance to leave a good impression on him!

That scandalous event was the last thing he wanted to see. He had taken a trip to Hell to earn the support of the dragon king, constructing his butt off for months in sweltering heat. And here he was, at last, in the presence of the king. Lloyd did not want a momentary mistake to ruin his first impression.

That can never happen. The dragon king must become my number one supporter.

An extra life. Endless treasure. Other additional rewards on top of everything. The dragon king was the very benefactor that would add one final, luxurious touch to Lloyd's opulent retirement. And so, he detested the thought of leaving a bad impression on him.

"Hmm! Ehem!" Lloyd cleared his throat. "Javier, I want you to politely wait."

Lloyd stopped Javier first, fearing that the latter might pull out his sword like a clueless fool. After that, he politely folded his hands and looked up at the manticore in the most respectful manner, his eyes glimmering and shining. Could it be that his tactic to be courteous worked? The Manticore's face started to soften as it gazed at Lloyd, and it stood up on its hind legs, lifted its chubby body, and motioned with its front paws.

"Cororog? Corong! Cororong!"

“...”

“Corong! Cororong!”

“Ahaha...” mumbled Lloyd. “Okay, yes...”

“Cororog? Corong! Corong!”

“Hmm, is that so? Ahaha...”

An awkward smile spread across Lloyd’s face. Javier inched closer to Lloyd and whispered, “Master Lloyd.”

“What, why?” replied Lloyd with slight annoyance.

“Do you understand what the manticore is saying?”

“No.”

“Then-”

“Shut your mouth first,” growled Lloyd under his breath. “You’re not the only one going bonkers over this.”

Lloyd wiped the cold sweat off him. This manticore was different from other fantastical creatures such as Ppodong. Lloyd couldn’t make the slightest sense of what the chubby lion wanted from him with its growling or motioning.

Goodness. What is this old, hairless creature saying?!

Just then, Lloyd wanted to burst into tears. If only he could, he wanted to give a hard pinch to its pinkish belly, which was splotchy with hair loss, until something hit him.

Wait, hold on.

Come to think of it, there were a few creatures that were briefly mentioned in the novel. Dragon King Verkis. And the five evil creatures that served

him.

I remember. Verkis was said to have them at his side.

Lloyd couldn’t recall everything about the five creatures. But he did manage to remember that a 26-feet long manticore was the leader among them.

Is this the creature mentioned in the novel?

Lloyd looked up at the manticore, his eyes now filled with wonder. His suspicion that it could be the creature he read about soon turned into conviction. If that was the case, he needed to confirm the truth before anything else.

“Excuse me,” Lloyd asked in a careful voice. “Are you here because Dragon King Verkis sent you?”

“Corong!”

The manticore nodded with a big smile on its face, and it started to gesture with more earnestness as though Lloyd could finally understand its words.

“Cororong! Corong? Corong!”

“Oh, wait, please gesture a bit more slowly...”

“Corong? Cororong! Corong!”

“Okay, so, you’re here to run an errand for Dragon King Verkis?” asked Lloyd.

“Cororong! Corong!”

“Oh, so you’re here to take me.”

“Corong!”

The manticore nodded again. And then, it gave its chubby butt to Lloyd and flopped to the ground before glancing at Lloyd and motioning toward its back with its jaw.

“Cororong!”

“You want me to ride on your back...?” Lloyd questioned with hesitation in his voice.

“Corong!”

“...”

It appeared so. Lloyd and Javier exchanged glances.

Javier nodded. “I will protect you if something happens.”

The manticore was evidently a powerful creature. A single angry manticore possessed the strength to wipe out one entire corps of elite human soldiers. Though it was as big as Ppodong, it easily transcended the latter in terms of combat power. Plus, a manticore as old as this one had to be a seasoned fighter on the battlefield. If Lloyd didn’t have Javier by his side, he’d have been left to pray that he wouldn’t be eaten up.

I’m glad that this fellow is on my side.

A sense of relief swelled over Lloyd and, trusting Javier, he hopped on the back of the manticore.

“Eh, um, please fly safely.”

“Corong!”

The manticore gave a snort as if there was nothing to worry about. And thus, a frenzied race began. *Kaboom!*

“Eek!!”

They grew far from the ground in a split second, and the view of their surroundings passed by them with overwhelming speed. Lloyd was able to avoid being thrown off to the ground by reflexively grabbing onto the creature's mane. It was only then that he was able to make out what was happening.

What kind of speed is this?!

The manticore was unbelievably fast. Lloyd was used to riding Ppodong and flying on Ggoming's back. However, the manticore was much faster than those two. It was so fast that the headwind blowing against his face made it difficult to breathe.

Argh!!

Fwoosh! The violent flurry of headwind blew against him, and his facial muscles and skin crumpled from the force. Even the air traveling into his nostrils felt like an invading enemy, making him feel they were being expanded three or four times wider. Lloyd had to cast his head down to breathe out. And as he could finally breathe, Lloyd started to grow excited.

What about Javier?

A thought popped into Lloyd's head. This was a golden opportunity. The powerful gust of headwind blowing against his facial muscle and skin had to be making Javier put on an ugly face too. Lloyd felt his heart race at the thought.

Oh, I wish I had a smartphone right now!

That way, he would be able to take a picture of Javier's funny face and keep it for eternity. He was regretful he couldn't but nonetheless excited about what he'd witness soon. Then Lloyd threw a glance toward Javier, only to find the knight looking perfectly fine and normal.

"Why are you looking at me like that, Young Master?" asked Javier calmly.

"Eh...?"

“For some reason, your eyes are much more sparkly than usual.”

“...”

Lloyd was left utterly speechless. Javier’s face was perfectly fine! It was completely normal despite the strong headwinds. He didn’t even have a single eyelash fluttering out of place.

This is not fair!

Lloyd inwardly screamed in disbelief. But could it be that Javier figured out what was happening? He scoffed at Lloyd.

“It looks like you are curious why my face is fine, unlike yours,” said Javier.

“...”

“Well, it is because I am a grandmaster,” added Javier matter-of-factly.

“...”

“I am currently using mana. Just in time, actually, as I was recently experimenting with how I can increase my body’s level of resistance against foreign forces. According to my calculation, it seems I can increase my skin's strength, elasticity, and sturdiness to that of metal. Like now.”

“It makes no sense,” Lloyd uttered, incredulous.

“It makes perfect sense.”

“How?!”

“Like this.”

Whoosh... Javier raised his hand. He straightened his index finger and stirred the air. Then a strand of brilliant aura appeared from the tip of his finger, which then drew an image in the air. But the image looked strange. It was a human face. A terribly ugly one. It looked like someone had stuffed

their head inside a stocking and was propelled dozens of feet in the air. Lloyd scowled.

“What is this wrinkly half-formed face?”

“This is what you look like now, Master Lloyd.”

“...”

“I am serious,” Javier went on, “You look extremely memorable. Avant-garde, even, I must say. Your face is usually plain, nothing much to enjoy. But now, with all the terrible crumpling, scrunching, and wrinkling from the wind, you are presenting a forever unforgettable sight to every beholder of your face, even with just a quick glance.”

A pang of shock left Lloyd speechless.

“How to describe this image…” Javier continued, his voice filled with delight. “It is a reinterpretation of the human face. Extremely powerful and dynamic, yet its asymmetrical uniqueness and singularity are clearly visible. This disharmony creates a multidimensional appearance that is completely outside the standard human face. It is remarkable. I feel your face is the new exemplar of asymmetry.”

“...”

Please, stop praising my face as if you’re viewing modern art. Despite the desire to say that thought out loud, Lloyd couldn’t do it. The manticore changed its direction, and the wind threw another hit to his face right before he could speak, causing a devastating tremble on his lips. He couldn’t fight back even though he wanted to. So, he was left to hold back his tears and promise himself to return this humiliation someday. Meanwhile, Javier continued to speak with a serious look on his face.

“Anyway,” Javier said, “what really is outrageous is the speed of this manticore.”

“Eh... Umph... Yes, I agree with you,” Lloyd replied, ducking his head to avoid the wind.

“It looks like the Dragon King Verkis has cast a special magic on this creature,” Javier said.

“Right?”

“Yes.”

It probably was the case. Sure, the manticore could be a powerful creature. But this speed simply just transcended the limits of biology.

Seriously, the dragon king is definitely something.

What would it feel like to be born like this? What good did this king do in his past life to be born with a silver spoon in his mouth and such outrageous powers?

Would it be enough to have saved a kingdom around a hundred times in your past life?

Lloyd was green with envy. As his thoughts dwelled on such, the snapshots of his surroundings changed in seconds, the mound suddenly becoming a river, which soon became a field and wilderness. Past several villages and cities and passing over the lake and valley, the manticore finally climbed up the foot of a mountain until a giant cave came into view.

A dragon’s cave, I suppose?

Gaffel is a neutral and autonomous city. Lloyd recalled how a dragon’s mountain sat there, in which Dragon King Verkis quietly resided. What stood right ahead of Lloyd seemed to be the very dragon’s cave in that mountain.

“Corong!”

The manticore continued its race toward the cave and passed through the well-polished and complicated passages. Lloyd’s eyes grew serious as he

studied them.

I knew it.

It was the dragon cave. Even though he couldn’t see thoroughly because everything was passing by in seconds, he noticed that the architecture was remarkable.

This entire place was built by carving and digging out the inside of a mountain. The rock foundation that makes up the mountain was used as the exterior of this dungeon.

Lloyd wondered how much capital and labor he would need if he had to deal with a project of this size. Chills ran down his spine just at the thought of it. Even with the surveying and design skills and the assistance of the fantastical creatures, a project with such an enormous demand, that is, to utilize this gigantic mountain itself as construction material, would require at least ten years.

No, I won’t be able to do it in even ten years. This is seriously no joke.

At the sight of the dungeon, Lloyd felt in his bones the sheer power of this dragon king. It wasn’t to be compared to the dungeon of Solitas, who matured only recently. That was how overwhelming this place was, and that was why Lloyd’s heart raced.

And the creator of that is going to become my ally.

In life, there are a few elements that must be cherished. A heartwarming family. Enough wealth to live by. Connections you could always rely on. And right now, Lloyd was about to acquire the last element, the best of the best connection. He had the heartwarming Frontera family. And he held enough wealth in the Frontera fiefdom. On top of those two, the support from Dragon King Verkis. Lloyd was just seconds away from setting up his life in luxurious retirement.

Lalalala! Wahahaha!

The humming came out naturally. It didn’t stop even when the manticore stopped and when he got off its back. He even did a joyful tap dance when his feet touched the ground. And he was led into the deepest part of the cave.

“Cororong! Corong!”

When he turned to the last corner, an empty cave welcomed his arrival. The length and width appeared to be several miles. The ceiling, too, was inconceivably high. There was more than enough space for several 656-foot dragons to do a full-court basketball game. Moreover, all kinds of treasure carpeted the whole area.

But despite the vast space and the overwhelming number of treasures that filled up the space, Lloyd didn’t bat an eye.

He couldn’t help it due to the sofa sitting randomly in the center of the cave with someone on it. The sight entranced Lloyd so ferociously that he couldn’t see anything else around him. It was the dragon king. Did the former grab Lloyd’s attention with a kingly charisma? Or with an oppressive dignity? Not at all.

What is this homebody doing here...?

Much like a father lazing around on a sofa over a weekend baseball game, the dragon king was lying on the sofa, as if he was a part of it. Lloyd couldn’t tell what was the sofa or the dragon king. That was Lloyd’s first impression of Dragon King Verkis.

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Chapter 247: The Sluggard’s Inner Thoughts (1)

A sluggard. In this world, sluggards come in various types. Case in point: there was Yeongjin, who only ate delivery food because he couldn’t be bothered to cook. And there was Daho, who only grilled one side of meat because he couldn’t be bothered to flip it with tongs. And there was the sluggish Sarin, who stayed all day in the house because removing sunblock before going to bed would just be too much work. And manager Park, the man who only parked outside buildings but never under a basement parking lot because the few steps to the elevator were just too far. As such, Lloyd was assured that he had more than his share of experience with sluggards back in Korea.

But now, his pride was falling apart. Why? Because the very first thought that crossed his mind upon seeing Dragon King Verkis at the center of the cave was...

What the heck is this wretched-looking homebody?

The thought just came to him. This sluggard was on a level of laziness that Lloyd had never seen before. He couldn’t help thinking otherwise. The king was lying flat on the sofa as if he was a part of it. Despite the fact that a human visitor came to his home and that this human was supposed to receive his support, the king didn’t rise. No, he didn’t even turn his head.

Swish. Instead, the king flickered his idle eye by point two centimeters over. And after a second of gazing...

Close.

Why is he going back to sleep?!

Lloyd exclaimed inwardly, completely flustered at what was happening. It never occurred to him that the dragon king would be a sluggard. Who would have imagined that the king would drift back to sleep without even saying a greeting? Lloyd expected the king to look stately and dominating

as he was the dragon king, the ruler reigning over every dragon in the world.

What should I do? Should I wake him up? Introduce myself? Maybe he will wake up to the sound.

Such a thought crossed his mind for a second, but he shook his head in resignation.

No, I think I'm rushing into things by waking him up.

His instinct told him so. Would the dragon king get on his feet and greet Lloyd just because the latter introduced himself and woke up the former? Would the king finally welcome Lloyd and remark on bestowing the promised awards in all of his stateliness?

No, I don't think that would be the case.

Lloyd shook his head again. He received the feeling that the dragon king was far from normal. If the king was the type to welcome Lloyd after being woken up, he wouldn't have fallen back asleep at the sight of the visitor in the first place.

Tsk. What should I do then?

Lloyd licked his lips in dismay. His job in Hell was done, and the only thing left was to receive his rewards. That was why he had come all the way here. And Dragon King Verkis, who was supposed to reward him, was irresponsibly asleep.

"Javier," called Lloyd.

"Yes, Master Lloyd."

"I think we should wait first."

Lloyd made a decision. He would act in discretion and refrain from waking the king up. If he let himself become blinded by the reward, he could ruin

everything by behaving recklessly. It would be like dropping a plate of fresh food on the ground.

Trying to keep his voice to a bare minimum, Lloyd whispered, “So, you should stay far away from here.”

“What about you?” asked Javier.

“Me? Well. I’ll have to dance to his tune.”

“By that, what do you mean?”

“I have a plan,” assured Lloyd. “So just keep quiet first.”

Lloyd motioned with his hands and sent Javier far away. Then he tiptoed toward the sleeping king as quietly and discreetly as possible and studied the latter. A sense of conviction and envy surged in Lloyd’s heart.

He’s really living like an unemployed hermit, spending all of his days lazing around. And yet, he’s the richest fellow in the world. Ha... Crap. I’m jealous.

A landlord. An individual whose properties were beyond enough to sustain their life. An individual who could idle around in the corner of a room scratching their feet while still making money. An individual who could live comfortably without any grand goals or passions in life. The life of an unemployed landlord was Lloyd’s dream life. Lloyd sensed that his role model was right in front of him.

I’m jealous. I’m dying of jealousy.

His stomach churned as he looked at the sleeping Dragon King Verkis. His heart thumped, and his lower abdomen ached. Was it all because of jealousy? Envy? No.

My gosh. He must be the brother I never had that I can look up to for the rest of my life.

Lloyd believed that life was all about making good friends, that is, those who liked to show off, splurge their money, and buy you food. Lloyd believed he should keep these kinds of friends by his side and treat them kindly to ensure they wouldn't go anywhere else. Flattery and praise were tools made for this purpose.

Service. Consideration. Respect. All of these precious and heartwarming universal values existed in the universe for moments like these. So, Lloyd collected his thoughts and picked up the high-end silk blanket lying around him, softly and gently putting it over Verkis.

My, my good friend. You might catch a cold if you sleep without anything to cover you.

Lloyd flashed a wide smile as though he was staring at a sleeping gold nugget or lucky charm. His acts of kindness didn't end there. Like a cockroach roaming around a kitchen sink at 2 AM, he slowly wandered around with caution until he found an item of his desire, a glass made of gold, which he used to draw spring water flowing around the area. And he also found a large peacock-feather fan with which he started fanning. When a soft breeze pleasingly tickled Verkis, his face started to appear more relaxed. At the same time, a content smile bloomed on Lloyd's face.

Perfect. It feels amazing to run a fan on its weakest setting while sleeping on a couch with a blanket over you. I guess it's the same for humans and dragons.

Lloyd recalled his experience. A long time ago, that is, before his family suffered from financial hardship, Lloyd lived in an ordinary apartment complex that had a leather sofa meant to fit three people at once. It was fluffy and comfortable. Nothing was more comfortable than lying there and watching TV. It wasn't entirely without any downside, however.

Since it was made out of leather, I started to sweat when I lay down for a long time.

That was the case even after placing down cushions. As he lay down, it grew hotter and hotter as the leather touching his body absorbed heat. When

that happened, he, without fail, brought out an electric fan and wrapped himself with a thin blanket while he let a light breeze cool him. That experience couldn’t be any more heavenly.

That will be the same for both humans and dragons.

As luck had it, the dragon king was idly lazing around on a leather sofa. This sight made Lloyd remember his time in South Korea, and he presented the king with a secret trick he frequently used back then. Unsurprisingly, the result was very successful.

Snore...

Could it be that the dragon king was feeling more relaxed? He started to snore aloud, which brought a smile to Lloyd’s face. But Lloyd was unaware of something. It was that Verkis, despite his snoring, was observing him.

What is that?

Dragon King Verkis thought to himself while half-asleep. While he snored at ease and regarded this human being pesky, he glanced at the human fanning at him.

This is my first time encountering a fellow like him.

This human had earned the right to his support. But he wasn’t the first one to win it. Several had come to him in the last hundreds of years, but they all gave up and returned empty-handed and without any support. The reason was simple. Verkis simply ignored them.

Why? I couldn’t be bothered.

Dealing with humans was a tedious job. It involved rising up from a sofa just to entertain a menial human being, which required him to move his back, body joints, and muscles. His arms also needed to touch the sofa, and his shoulder needed to be tensed. Even more, he had to lift his head and open his eyes to focus them on the human. As though that wasn’t enough, he had to chat. That involved unnecessary moving of his mouth.

He despised all of it. It was all a chore. He couldn’t stand the thought of wasting several seconds of his life as a dragon to needlessly move. Instead, he could use the time to let his muscles and red blood cells rest. It would make his heart ache to waste his life that way. It would hurt him. And so, Verkis ignored all his visitors. He simply kept sleeping without opening his eyes. Surprisingly, however, this pesky problem of his resolved on its own when he did.

All the visitors became flustered at first. But then they would start to beg and throw a fit before eventually turning back.

The candidates set to obtain his support had behaved all the same. First, they were caught off-guard by his absence of a reaction. One even got fidgety and tried to wake him up. But Verkis shut his senses completely to them. Then most started to beg and get clingy. Dear dragon king, please open your eyes. Do not turn your eyes against me. Wake up, soldier. And yet, Verkis kept sleeping, persistently ignoring their pleas. Afterward, their subsequent reaction was anger.

They burst with anger when they realized they were being ignored. Why? Most of the humans had a great sense of pride.

Normally, earning the right to receive support from Dragon King Verkis involved accomplishing something massively grand. Something that was beyond human capacity, like saving a dragon, for example. In the first place, the achievement wasn’t something any ordinary human could accomplish, so humans with such feats were far from ordinary. They were the heroes of the world. Swordsman beyond human limits. The most powerful magician. The cleric once considered the saint of the world. Or even a conqueror the world will remember. Each and every single one of them who came here to attain the right to receive support from the king was worthy of making into human epic tales. But they all failed to achieve what they came here for.

Their pride was just too strong.

A faint smile spread across Verkis’s face. These heroes swelled with pride and ego due to their great achievements that would certainly be

remembered in history. With that in mind, it wasn't hard to imagine their reaction to being blatantly and persistently disregard for the first time in their lives inside the very dragon cave that they waltzed into with anticipation of amazing rewards. It crushed them.

They couldn't handle it.

At first, they begged in tears. Later on, they whined that even a dragon king shouldn't behave this way and treat them with such disregard. They angrily cried out that it was a violation of their promise. Eventually, they went back after a few days, months, or even years of Verkis continuing to ignore them in his sleep.

Of course, he was upbraided by his wife for it. She gave him an earful that he shouldn't be doing this again. The visitors had traveled far and long and didn't deserve such harsh treatment. Why are you not fulfilling the Dragon King support system your mother and sister painstakingly strove to create? It wasn't right for him to laze around like this. What happened to the promise he made before getting married to become hard-working? She berated him for giving her an empty, short-lasting promise. His wife's scolding lasted for months.

Well, it's still okay.

Verkis grinned inwardly. It was amusing to hear his wife scold him and made him feel happy. The sound of her chattering couldn't please him enough. And so, ignoring the visitors was a good thing. He was saved from entertaining them against his will, and it invited nice scolding from his wife. Thus, killing two birds with one stone. So, Verkis believed it would be the same for this human visitor, who just arrived with a foolish smile on his face. Lloyd must have come in excitement to receive his support. That Verkis's first thought when he saw the human. The man was no different from the other human heroes he had seen. As such, all he had to do was treat him the same way as the rest. He was quite convinced up until a second ago.

Who is this man?

Verkis was starting to become speechless.

He's helping me fall asleep instead?

Yes. This human who just entered the cave. This man wasn't throwing a tantrum or begging or making formal and polite remarks to wake him up from his slumber. Instead of those, this one put a blanket over him and fanned him instead of saying anything. There was more.

He even got me a glass of water. Is that for me to drink when I wake up?

It appeared so. The way Verkis looked at Lloyd changed slightly.

Ha. This fellow. I like him.

Lloyd was different from all the other human visitors he encountered. Verkis liked Lloyd because it looked like he wouldn't bother him too much. So he was able to fall asleep more comfortably.

Okay. I like him. This is your reward. I'll unintentionally ignore you instead of doing it on purpose.

Verkis made up his mind to fall asleep for real. This was something he hardly did to anybody. And so, he thought that Lloyd should consider this an honor of a lifetime. Verkis shut his half-closed eyes all the way with a sense of immense satisfaction and fell asleep, determined to sleep for a few years.

Snore... Aphew...

His entire body relaxed, and he plunged into dreamland. The king thought that the human fanning him would be gone by the time he woke up. If so, he would let out a big yawn after opening his eyes and kiss his wife after receiving another scolding from her.

Verkis set up a solid sleep plan. Of course, even when he drifted into a deep sleep, he didn't worry a single bit. He wasn't worried at all about a rancorous human attacking him while he was asleep. In the first place, no attack could hurt him. Even if a supernova explosion occurred right in front

of his face, he would only get a small scrape that stung his nose and nothing more.

No creature in this world was capable of hurting him. Verkis went back to sleep with complete peace of mind. And so, he was entirely clueless. He was completely unaware of what outrageous plan Lloyd, who had been politely serving him, was about to put in place.

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Chapter 248: The Sluggard’s Inner Thoughts (2)

Snore... Phew...

The dragon cave. This was the home of Dragon King Verkis, and it was a divine place worshiped by all dragons. Its vast space in the dungeon could accommodate a full-court basketball game played by ten gigantic dragons. And through that very space rang the snoring noise of Dragon King Verkis. He was extremely comfortable in his current position fused together to the couch with the soft blanket the human had put on him. Moreover, there was a fresh freeze from the human’s fanning. It couldn’t get any more restful than this. Verkis’s eyes shut on their own, leading him into dreamland. And just like that, Verkis fell into a deep slumber. This made the corners of Lloyd’s lips pull up.

Whew, it’s done.

Lloyd put on a rewarding smile on his face, having succeeded in putting the sluggard to sleep. He then cast a quick glance to Verkis who was in a comatose state. And to make sure that the latter was completely knocked out, Lloyd waved his hands before the king’s face. As expected, he received no reaction, and instead...

Phewww! Snore...

His breathing grew more relaxed. It had happened. Verkis was fully asleep. With that conviction, Lloyd tiptoed away from him.

Javier, who had been observing Lloyd since a while ago, asked, “Master Lloyd, what did you do?”

“What do you think?” Lloyd grinned at Javier. “I helped the dragon king fall asleep.”

“I saw that myself, so I know that,” replied Javier, whose face grew suspicious. “I am asking what you are up to by putting him to sleep.”

“Two things,” replied Lloyd with a shrug.

“Two things?”

“Yeah,” said Lloyd. “One is not upsetting the king. I could feel it the moment I saw him. Did you see it, too? How he fell right back to sleep without giving a single greeting even when he saw us.”

“Yes, I have seen it.”

“Right?”

“Yes, he reminded me of your previous self.”

“What?” Lloyd raised his brow, surprised by what he just heard.

Javier’s face straightened. “I mean how it used to be impossible to wake up after a night of drinking.”

Having never expected Javier to say this, Lloyd was left speechless.

“I am not sure if you remember,” continued Javier, “but that is exactly what you were like. You refused to get out of bed. The more I tried to wake you up, the more upset you’d get and hurl insults as well as physical objects at me.”

“...”

“Now that I think about those days, I can understand your intentions at the moment. I agree with you. It would be very upsetting to wake someone up by force when they wish to get some more sleep.”

“...”

Lloyd wasn’t sure whether what he just heard was a compliment or another unrestrained insult from Javier. Whatever it was, he felt a slight sense of resentment and a bit wronged.

Dammit. The Lloyd you saw then wasn’t me, you bastard.

But no one in this world, including Javier, would be aware of this. The truth was only known to him and only for him to know. These false accusations were something he had to accept for the rest of his life. When he thought so, he was able to plaster a shameless face and give a snort.

“Tsk. You never pull your punches while insulting someone. Anyway, as you say, I intend to not upset the dragon king before anything else,” admitted Lloyd, his voice sounding slightly bitter.

“Then what is the second one?”

“Having fun.”

“Excuse me...?” Javier’s eyes widened a shade.

“Didn’t you hear me? I’m going to have fun.”

“Wait, here?”

“Yeah.” Lloyd earnestly nodded as if there was no other way around it. He then continued, “Think about it. The dragon king called for us, even sent us the manticore, and said nothing when he saw us in here. What could that mean? It means we’re officially an invited guest here, don’t you think?”

“You are right, but...” Javier protested feebly.

“We should have fun as invited guests here,” reasoned Lloyd. “The dragon king is out like a light, and we can’t force him to wake up. And it’s not like he’s going to be asleep for years. So, we should enjoy ourselves while we wait.”

Javier caught the excitement in Lloyd’s voice. He then asked, “Then what are you going to do to have fun?”

“Laze around.”

The corners of Lloyd’s lips pulled up. To laze around like an unemployed bum. It was something that Lloyd wanted to try all his life. And watching

the dragon king slumbering on his couch like that only reinforced Lloyd's desire. That was how exhausted he was.

"To be honest," Lloyd said, "I want to get some rest. Think about it. How long have I been working?"

"Um, almost five months from Hell, and..."

"And before I headed down to Hell, I worked on the construction of the Termina Garden for about six months for the queen, right?"

"Yes."

"Right? So, know that you're looking at a person who worked for almost a year straight without a single break," said Lloyd.

"How diligent of you."

"I don't want that sort of compliment."

"How restless you have been."

"Yes, you're right. That is why I'm doing this." Lloyd pointed to the inside of the spacious empty cave. "This is more like a long-awaited vacation for us. Who can reach me when I'm in here, right?"

It was true. In a way, this was the safest place in the whole world since this was the place resided by the dragon king. So no one would dare venture their way here or come to call Lloyd. This place offered absolute freedom and rest, free from anyone's interruption. So from then onward, Lloyd had the run of the whole cave and went all out in enjoying his break. It was a vacation, a kind of hocance. What was more, there was a resting area that was on par with a five-star hotel. Believe it or not, that area was the royal castle. And there were two of them.

"It looks like... These castles have been plucked out from somewhere," observed Lloyd.

Two royal castles sat in the corner of the cave, and he was flabbergasted at first when he spotted them during his adventure around the cave. No matter how he looked at it, from the left and right, the structure in front of him was the royal castle. But something was off about its lower half.

There are signs that it has been ripped, no, plucked off.

Lloyd was sure. The supporting structure of the entire castle, along with a portion of its lower foundation, had been ripped apart to be transferred here. Just then, Lloyd recalled an old memory.

Right. The novel mentioned this. I think it was around the time the royal capital Magenta had a different name. There was a foolish king who lost two royal castles to a dragon. And I had a conversation about this with the messenger the first time I went to the capital.

He remembered now. The story was something he definitely heard about before. And now, it turned out...

The dragon that plucked the castle is Dragon King Verkis!

The situation became clear to Lloyd at last. Dragon King Verkis had plucked out the royal castle like a radish on a field and brought it all the way here.

Then he used it as decoration for his house.

Lloyd felt dazed for some reason, but he immediately shook it off. Since they were already here, Lloyd figured that he should take a good look inside. And soon, he noticed something.

The inside is a lot more well-kept than I imagined!

It was a surprise. The whole castle shone with gloss as though somebody had cleaned it this morning. Not a single speck of dust could be found throughout the palace. And what was more, even the bed in every room was dry and fluffy!

Hahaha. This is amazing.

Lloyd made a decision. If not now, he would never get a chance to sleep on a king's bed. So he hurried and settled in the king's bedroom, ready to enjoy his vacation to the fullest.

The cave, moreover, held plenty of food. Around the center of the vast empty cave, there extended spiderweb-like passages that grew sweet potatoes underneath their dirt. The sweet potatoes were tremendously large, the same size as a basketball.

"Hey, let's grill it," suggested Lloyd to Javier.

"..."

"What are you doing?" hurried Lloyd when he saw Javier staying wordless. "Start a fire."

"..."

Lloyd had just walked over carrying five giant sweet potatoes in his arms, and Javier stared at him, completely dazed and speechless.

Javier asked, "They look like valuable produce from the dragon cave. Are we allowed to grill them without permission?"

"Yeah, probably," replied Lloyd nonchalantly.

"How do you know?"

"I asked the manticore," replied Lloyd, maintaining the same tone of nonchalance.

Indeed, he did. Fearing that getting sweet potatoes could invite the wrath of Verkis, Lloyd went up to the manticore just to make sure. And he asked matter-of-factly if he could eat some of the sweet potatoes lying around the area.

The manticore gave a very chill "YES."

"Corong! That was how it answered," Lloyd explained.

“Are you sure that was an affirmation?” asked Javier dubiously.

“Yup. The manticore nodded as it coronged.”

“And that counts as receiving permission?”

“Of course,” replied Lloyd as he placed down the sweet potatoes. “And I even introduced it to Ppodong to show my gratitude.”

“Sir Ppodong?”

“Yeah. The manticore cocked its head at first. But when it saw Ppodong grow large after eating the red sunflower seed, it was very welcoming.”

Javier mused, “I see. Indeed, the two are fairly similar in size.”

“It appears so. Thankfully, Ppodong got along with the manticore pretty quickly.”

“So, are they playing right now?”

“Yeah,” said Lloyd, “Probably playing tag. Anyway, when are you going to start the fire?”

“...”

“Hurry up now. I’m starving.”

“...”

And just like that, the hero, who saved the world in the original novel, was degraded into becoming a sweet potato griller with a face full of soot. Like so, in the next few days, Lloyd idly lazed around, making up for all the days he spent being overworked and exhausted. He was relaxed, happy, and content. On the other hand, Javier observed Lloyd with a strange gaze.

“...”

Ten days had passed since they came to this cave, and Javier started to have a realization. The Lloyd in front of him wasn’t real. He was a man from another world.

That was why he suddenly seemed to behave like a different person.

Javier recalled one morning a few years back. Lloyd had thrown a nasty drunken fit the night before. But when the following morning rolled around, he acted like a completely different person. It was strange, but Javier let it slide because the change was rather welcoming.

Now I know. The meaning behind the name he was called by the King of Hell, Suho Kim.

Suho Kim. Javier figured that it must be the name of fake Lloyd back in his world. So, the unexpected actions and mysterious knowledge of construction displayed by this man until now must have been a product of his own world. At last, he was able to get some clarification. Javier finally understood what happened. On the one hand, he also became curious.

That fake Master Lloyd... How would he react if he knows that I know? Would he act shamelessly like he always does? Or would he get scared? How should I react when such a day comes?

There wasn’t any way of knowing. However, one thing was clear.

As long as you don’t change from now, I will protect you by your side until the end.

Faint warmth filled Javier’s gaze as it fixed on Lloyd. But when the latter noticed Javier’s gaze, he cocked his head to the side and asked, “Hey, what’s on your mind right now?”

“Excuse me?” Javier replied, taken aback.

“You just gave me a really cheesy look.”

“...”

“Tell me honestly,” Lloyd went on, “You’re hiding that you’ve found something tastier than sweet potatoes, right?”

“Not at all,” replied Javier, feeling relieved.

“Really?”

“Yes,” assured Javier again and chuckled, thinking to himself that there actually was something he was currently hiding but planned to keep hiding his secret for the time being.

Lloyd chuckled too and said, “Then hurry up and grill the sweet potatoes. I’m hungry.”

“Understood.”

With that, Javier started to busy himself with roasting the sweet potatoes, and another day passed by as the two enjoyed their long-awaited vacation. At the same hour, in the corner of the cave, Verkis, who was happily sleeping, felt a sense of crisis and flew open his eyes.

♣

“Eek..?!”

Dragon King Verkis opened his eyes, but was it because his sleeping position was uncomfortable? Or because Lloyd stopped fanning a cool breeze over him? No. The sofa was comfortable even without a cool breeze. The reason why he abruptly woke up after feeling a sense of crisis was simple.

This is bad. I’ve forgotten the most important thing.

Verkis recalled the promise he had been forgetting all this time, the promise he had made with his lovely wife.

I promised to contact her every day...!

But it slipped his mind completely, and he never made any calls. Since when?

I don't know. How long did I doze off?

Verkis searched his memory for the last time he wasn't half-asleep. That very day, his wife had gone out to the world with his mother dragon for a trip.

She told me that they'd be traveling for about a year and reiterated that I should call her every morning.

It was homework, in a way. But it had slipped his mind altogether. Verkis felt his heart tighten in nervousness. So, he immediately raised his hand and created a magic circle in the air to activate advanced communication magic that allowed him to contact her wherever she was.

Swaa....! The magic circle rotated in the air and tracked her coordinates before attempting connection. Then it failed.

Crash! The communication magic circle then vanished in thin air. The connection was lost. Verkis knew why this happened.

"She... rejected my call."

This was bad, really bad. His wife was sulking now.

What should I do?

Verkis racked his brain. His wife was an angel, so she never became upset over anything. But given that his call was denied, it appeared that she was really angry this time. Verkis wondered how he should fix this situation.

Should I run to her right now and beg for forgiveness? No. That's too much work.

He didn't want to fly such a long journey. That demanded a lot of muscle movement. And he would even have to use space teleportation which would require him to activate a large amount of mana. That was too much work.

What should I do then?

Verkis deliberated how he could appease his wife with minimal effort.

“Ugh... Think. Think...”

Verkis wrapped his head with his hands, racking his brain fiercely. Just then, while Verkis was lost in his deliberation, someone approached him from behind and spoke.

“My, dear Dragon King!” The man’s voice dripped with shamelessness. “Pray, do tell me, is there something bothering you?”

The voice belonged to Lloyd, who ran all the way here the moment he realized that the king had woken up. He then politely rubbed his hands together to make sure that he was making a good first impression before audaciously offering several words of flattery to him. And he plastered the smile of a fraudulent insurance salesman on his face as he gazed at Verkis.

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Chapter 249: Becoming the Dragon King's Alarm (1)

"My, dear Dragon King!" The man's voice dripped with shamelessness. "Pray, do tell me, is there something bothering you? Or a problem on your mind?"

"..."

A voice suddenly tickled his ears. Dragon King Verkis turned and found a human standing there, rubbing his hands and tightly smiling in a friendly manner. Verkis cocked his head.

"What are you?" blurted Verkis.

"Excuse me?"

"Who are you to stand here right now in front of me-"

"Oh, I am Lloyd Frontera," broke in Lloyd. "It is nice to meet you. I was brought here by a manticore as I have somehow become eligible to receive your sponsorship by some unexpected turn of events. Do you not remember? I even put on a blanket over you and fanned you a few days ago. Oh, and this."

"..."

"I brought water just in case you were thirsty after waking up. Try drinking this refreshing cup of cold water first."

"..."

Verkis stared at Lloyd with a strange gaze, trying to make sense of him. And soon, he started to recall what had happened.

Right. This fellow crawled into my dungeon a few days ago.

Verkis remembered that this man, who attained the right to receive his sponsorship, got here with the help of the manticore. It had been 150 years

since he last saw a visitor, but he couldn’t bother entertaining him. The mere act of talking to a human being was bothersome, and so was shifting his eyes to get a look at him. Thus, Verkis fell back to sleep, much like he did to the few heroes who had set foot here. If he slept and ignored him, this human would leave on his own like the others. Thinking that he would eventually give up on receiving his sponsorship, Verkis fell into a sound slumber.

But it turned out that giving up must have been the last thing on this human’s mind. And it didn’t seem like he would beg like the other heroes, who had pleaded for their rewards and for the king to keep his promise. Lloyd didn’t straightforwardly demand anything from him either. Instead of begging and clinging to him, this groveling human offered to help.

Verkis swallowed his smile and took the glass of water. After drinking, he said, “You? Me? Help out?”

“Yes, my lord,” replied Lloyd.

“How? Do you plan to lend an ear to me or something like that?”

“My, if I could help you out by listening, then I’m ready to lend you an ear a hundred times over.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded earnestly, sensing that this was a golden opportunity.

I was getting a shade jittery about when the dragon king would wake up, but thankfully, the opportunity came earlier than I imagined.

Even when Lloyd was enjoying his vacation in the cave for the past few days, he didn’t feel completely at peace. In fact, he had kept his eyes and ears open for the dragon king at all times. Even when he was goofing around on the king’s bed, looking around the area set up with traps in the cave, and roasting sweet potatoes to ease his hunger, Lloyd was on full alert

in order to avoid missing any movements from the dragon king. And so, a part of him had started to grow worried.

It seemed like the dragon king was going to sleep longer than I expected.

At first, Lloyd believed that the king wouldn't sleep for more than a few days. But as time progressed, he realized that wasn't the case. The king looked like he was going to sleep a few months straight. So, Lloyd was on the fence about whether to wait some more or figure out another way.

Thankfully, the dragon king woke up by himself at a great time. My, how thankful I am.

What was more, Verkis didn't just wake up. It looked like something was terribly bothering his mind. This was a golden opportunity that would be difficult to come across again. Thinking so, Lloyd hurriedly decided to take action.

"I am ready to listen to whatever it is that is bothering you, my king. Am I troubled by this? Not at all. Why would I feel troubled? This world is all about helping each other! We should all treat one another with kindness!That is the beautiful future we should work toward."

"..."

"Please forgive me," apologized Lloyd when he noticed Verkis was being silent. "I got carried away."

"Let's move on. So, you are willing to hear out my concern, is that right?" Verkis asked.

"Yes."

"Then are you married?"

"Excuse me?" Lloyd's brow lifted.

"I said, are you married?" reiterated Verkis.

“No, I am not.”

“Then are you in a relationship?”

“No,” replied Lloyd.

“Have you ever been in one up to this point?”

“No...”

“What kind of life have you been living?” huffed Verkis.

“...”

Come on, Dragon King. There’s no need to hurt me with your words, said Lloyd to himself, trying to hold back the tears starting to well in his eyes. But Verkis was cruel and merciless.

“You’re not married, and you never had a girlfriend. I doubt that you will be a good listener. You wouldn’t know the struggles of a married man,” dismissed Verkis.

“Oh! I know a little,” exclaimed Lloyd.

“How?”

“I used to lend an ear to my dad all the time. By that, I mean whenever my mother was upset.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“Hmm, I suppose you can help me a little to solve this emergency crisis of my sulking sweetheart,” mused Verkis.

“What do you mean by sweetheart?”

“My wife.”

“Your wife... Oh, the dragon queen?”

“Yes.”

“Please speak. I am all ears.”

Lloyd then got down on his knees, bringing his body slightly toward Verkis. And he even wiggled his ears by moving the muscles behind his head to persuade the dragon king of his desire to hear about his problem. This attitude of his touched the latter’s heart.

“Tsk... It’s simple. My sweetheart is upset.”

“She is?”

“Yes.”

“What happened...?”

“She went on a trip with my mother and daughter.”

“Your mother and daughter?”

“Yeah,” Verkis went on to explain. “You wouldn’t know this, but she is extremely diligent. Beyond what you can imagine. For hundreds of years of her life here, she has never missed a day of cooking or cleaning.”

“Oh,” said Lloyd, understanding the situation. “Could that be the reason why your mother took your wife on a trip?”

“Oh? Correct. You’re quite clever.”

“I made a rough guess.”

“Anyway, you’re right. My mother felt sorry seeing my wife do nothing but housework and thought she was living too diligently to enjoy life. So, she suggested getting some fresh air together. And just like that, Mother took off, telling me that they’d be traveling for just a year.”

“Your mother has taken your wife?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.” Verkis nodded his head. “So, I was left here all alone. You know, this is an opportunity.”

“That is true. It is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity. You can do whatever you want to do all by yourself. And laze around,” seconded Lloyd.

“That’s exactly right. I see you aren’t completely clueless.”

“Ahaha.”

“Anyway, so I planned on sleeping to my heart’s content, but it turned out my wife knew what was going on in my head already. So, she gave me some homework.”

“Homework? What was it?” Lloyd was intrigued.

“She wanted me to call her every morning.”

“...”

“In verbatim, she said, ‘My dear husband, for the first time, I will be going around the world away from your side. As such, I am truly worried about you, who will be left alone all those days. So, I wish for you to call me every morning and tell me how you are.’”

“Ahahaha... How sweet,” mumbled Lloyd uncertainly.

“But scary,” Verkis added.

“Yes, it is.”

Lloyd seconded without any hesitation. When he thought about it, there was something scary about those gentle and sweet-sounding words.

Really, it’s the gentle suggestions that are truly scary.

Lloyd’s mind flew back to the days when he lived in South Korea, particularly the times when his father got grilled by his mother. And Lloyd noticed that Dragon King Verkis had an expression that was similar to his father’s during those past occasions.

“I will never understand.” Verkis shook his head. “Call her every morning? What kind of lifestyle in this world does one, no, a dragon need to wake up every morning on their own? Is that even possible?”

“Oh, that’s a challenge to all the humans of this world as well,” agreed Lloyd gravely.

“Is that true? I’m not the strange one here, right?”

“You’re not.” Lloyd playfully agreed with Verkis again, pointing out the crux of the latter’s concern. “Wait, have you not called her at all in the meantime?”

“No.”

“How long has it been?”

“I’m not exactly sure, but I believe it’s been about a month.”

“Did you try today...?”

“Of course I did. I tried through communication magic but failed.”

“It can’t be.” Lloyd gaped.

“You catch on quickly.”

“She denied your call. Am I right?”

“Yes. So, help me out here. How can I overcome this emergency crisis?”

“...”

Lloyd clamped his mouth shut, wondering how he should help out and what benefit he might be able to get out of it. He analyzed the situation, calculating it all piece-by-piece. He did the math for what his potential gains and losses were. And at last, a conclusion was reached.

“Um, I would like to ask one thing... Visiting the dragon queen is something you are not considering, right?” asked Lloyd carefully.

“Of course not. She’ll lash out at me if I go there now.”

“Right.”

Verkis couldn’t be any more right. Recklessly approaching a sulking wife was the same as asking for death. So, the dragon king had to appease her before he could go see her, and that was his main point of concern. How would he be able to soothe her anger? Thankfully, Lloyd had an answer.

With confidence, Lloyd said, “Then come to my fiefdom.”

“What?” Verkis tilted his head. “Me? You want me to come to your fiefdom?”

“Yes.”

“That sounds cumbersome. But why?”

“That way I can give you a wake-up call every morning,” explained Lloyd.

“A wake-up call?”

“Yes.”

Now came the crucial part. Lloyd licked his lips before putting on a sweeter and gentler smile on his face. And he spoke in a voice that said, “You can trust me.”

“Think about it, my king,” explained Lloyd, “You said it earlier. What kind of lifestyle does a dragon need to wake up on his own?”

“Yes, I did.”

“I agree with you. There is nothing more difficult and agonizing than waking up on your own every morning. But what if you have someone to wake you up?”

“Someone to wake me up? Are you suggesting you would wake me up?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded confidently, and in an honest, trustworthy, and credible voice, he said, “I will wake you up every morning at the same hour, so you can call your wife.”

“Hmm, but what if she doesn’t answer?”

“You should keep trying nonetheless.”

“Will it work?”

“It will,” replied Lloyd with equal confidence. “The dragon queen is enraged because your promise to call her every day was broken. The events of the past cannot be changed, and your fault will not be erased. But as everything is with life, your realization that it’s too late is the earliest time to take corrective action. So, you should dutifully contact her every morning from now on.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes, and of course, she will ignore your call a few times. But what do you think will happen if you keep calling her? Eventually, she will come around. Why? You will be showing her how remorseful you feel, even if you can’t reach her.”

“Hmm. That sounds logical,” replied Verkis, accepting Lloyd’s suggestion.

“Yes, and I am here to help you out.”

“So, you will wake me up every morning?”

“Yes, all you need to do is laze, no, sleep all day until I wake you up to contact your wife.”

“After that will I be able to sleep for the rest of the day until you wake me up the next morning?”

“Exactly, what is more...” Lloyd paused before speaking. “Think how pleased she will be when she learns that you stepped out of this cave.”

“And that’s why you’re insisting we go to your fiefdom,” postulated Verkis, nodding.

“Yes, exactly.”

Lloyd smiled, swelling with confidence. A satisfied smile appeared on Verkis’s mouth as well.

Good.

Verkis and Lloyd. The dragon king and the sly human. Both of them had the same thought in their heads.

This fellow is quite useful!

Verkis’s eyes blossomed with hope as he looked at Lloyd. His suggestion was good even when the king thought about it again. There wasn’t much he needed to do other than just sleep like usual until the boy woke him up when it was time to call his wife. The human had seemingly solved his biggest problem after being left alone in the dragon cave.

That manticore of mine is reluctant to wake me up from sleep. It’s still afraid of me.

But that thorny issue was about to be solved very soon. And it didn’t look like he was losing anything from the deal. Content, Verkis shot a glance toward Lloyd.

“So, you must be expecting something big in return,” stated Verkis.

“Yes.”

“You won’t even pretend to be modest?” Verkis was slightly dumbstruck.

“What would be the point of that considering you’ve already seen through me?” Lloyd dared to say. “That would only bother you into saying a few more words.”

“Wow. I like your way of thinking.”

“Thank you, my lord.”

“Fine. I’ll give it to you.”

“Come again?” Lloyd paused, and just then, Verkis flicked his fingers. *Snap!*

“Done. An additional life and access to this cave. I gave it all to you.”

“What...?”

“Those were the benefits that have been promised to come with my sponsorship. I just gave them to you. All of it,” Verkis said dully.

“All of it?”

Lloyd was dazed. With just a flick of his finger, he gave him all of the promised rewards? Lloyd couldn’t believe it.

“What? Did you expect to see something sparkle or flash? Hm? I can’t be bothered to add those unnecessary showy effects,” said Verkis as he wrinkled his brow.

“I-is that so?”

“Of course. From now on, you have free access to this cave. You won’t trigger any of the traps. So, you can take whatever trinket you want from here. Plus, as for the additional life...” Verkis stroked his jaw.

“Yes,” replied Lloyd with a gulp.

“There isn’t a way for me to immediately verify this all to you,” finally said Verkis. “Hmm, or you could die right now. Want to try?”

“No...”

“All right, good thinking.” Verkis nodded. “Moreover, I’m sure you’ve also factored in the rewards you’d be getting by serving me in your fiefdom, right?”

“Yes.”

“At least pretend to be embarrassed if you’ve been caught.”

“Ahaha.”

Lloyd smiled in embarrassment. What Verkis just pointed out was true. Lloyd would be serving the former at least for a year, and this time would grant him the opportunity to curry even more favor from the king. He would dance to his tune and earn a little more brownie points from him. Lloyd figured that his connection with Verkis would come to be helpful for the rest of his life.

I mean, he’s the dragon king. The richest bum in the whole world!

Once again, Lloyd told himself that he had to keep this man by his side. He would serve Verkis as his great role model and ally even if it required Lloyd to pander to him. His life would be greatly enriched by building a constructive and close relationship with him

Plus, there isn’t any hard work involved for me to help the king like this.

He just needed to wake the king up every morning. That was easier than taking a dog out for a walk.

And in return, I’m building a connection with the dragon king. I should jump to take this chance come hell or high water

.

With only one gram of effort, he earned an equivalent of 1,000 tons in gains. Lloyd wasn’t the type to miss out on such a reward.

“So, can I escort you now, my king?” suggested Lloyd.

“Are you going to carry me on your back?”

“That way, you will be free from the tedious job of walking.”

“I like you. You’re my type of guy. But what you just suggested is creepy, so leave it. Let’s just teleport.”

“Yes, duly noted.”

Lloyd agreed right away, and Verkis prepared to teleport. The sly human and lazy dragon king. The two’s interests were perfectly aligned at this very moment. And Javier watched everything that was happening by their side. He thought to himself...

That fraud.

Javier wondered if this man, Suho Kim, used to be a scammer in his world and asked himself if he was wasting his energy to protect such a con man. Amid the growing sense of resentment, he started packing nonetheless to get ready to return to his fiefdom. And just like that, the two humans and the dragon king were set to depart for the Frontera fiefdom.

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Chapter 250: Becoming the Dragon King’s Alarm (2)

Frontera fiefdom. The province that sat at the far east of the Magentano Kingdom. Originally, it was a shabby, good-for-nothing boondocks, but recently, it had been reborn as the hottest hub for development in the whole kingdom. Even today, its coal mine produced plumes of dark smoke, and the ondol laid out on house floors warmed up the carpets. There was also the arable land that evolved from the Maritz Wetland, the terraced fields, the water system that ran constantly to produce clean water, the generous apartment complex, and the water sewage system for human wastes, no other fiefdom in the entire kingdom with such advanced technologies.

Furthermore, the Frontera fiefdom received a generous amount of funding from the royal palace. There were plenty of supplies for reconstruction arriving on a monthly basis. It was similar to having thousands of tons worth of food delivered for free every month. There was more. The water bill from the Lacona viscounty. The slope stabilization maintenance fee from the Namaran fiefdom. All of it was an excellent source of financial capital.

And moreover... haa. We received more Elensia sap from the elf village this month too. It’s amazing how we can obtain one whole bottle of such precious sap in exchange for just 30 bags of coal. Lloyd told me to store it in the warehouse as soon as it arrived, right?

Count Arcos Frontera recalled what Lloyd had said and busied himself.

Psh! Fwoosh! Thwack! The trowel moved busily at the hard-working hands of the count, and each time, the weeds that tried to take residence in the manor’s garden disappeared. Count Arcos’s heart grew lighter with it.

“Whew.”

The fiefdom had everything it could possibly need. Its future was solid, and on top of it, the count’s two sons were dutifully moving forward to build their own future. As the owner of the fiefdom and head of the family, Count Frontera couldn’t be any more satisfied.

“Isn’t that true, my love?” Count Arcos asked.

“Come again?” Countess Marbella cocked her head at the question, stopping her job with the trowel. “What do you mean by that, honey?”

“Just. I am happy with how light and warm my heart feels. The weather is nice. Speaking of, what do you say we go horseback riding in the afternoon?”

“You are not suggesting we should race, are you?” asked Countess Marbella.

“Of course not. Let’s ride together with one of us in the front and back. Pressed close to each other,” suggested Count Arcos with a smile.

“My dear, how you make me blush.” Countess Marbella turned away.

“Hahaha, do you feel shy?”

“No, it is not that.”

“Then?”

“Only that I cannot believe you brought up such a pleasant suggestion just now,” she looked down as she said.

“Hahaha!”

The two then erupted into a hearty burst of laughter. Though they were squatting down with their hands muddied from working on the garden, the sensation of the dirt gave them joy. And even the sun looked particularly bright and beautiful today. Just like that, under the cozy sunlight, both looked around before they brought their lips close. Just then, all of a sudden, a magic circle appeared in the air beside the flower garden. *Bzzt! Swaa!*

“Eek...?”

“My!”

The two jumped back right before their lips touched. However, they were still holding each other's hands as they stared at the magic circle, which disappeared a second later until it was replaced with three people and a giant lump.

"Whoa..."

Lloyd staggered as he stepped on the ground after the teleport magic circle vanished.

Ugh. I feel sick.

Up until a moment ago, Lloyd was at the center of the dragon cave when Verkis flicked his finger. One snap and everything drastically changed. A mana wave enveloped the whole surrounding, floating his body. All sorts of lights shimmered around him. But they only lasted for a second. By the time his feet touched the ground, the entire scenery around him had been altered. Instead of the inside of the vast cave, the warm and familiar garden of his manor came into Lloyd's view. And then he also saw two welcoming faces of people who fell to the ground by surprise at his appearance.

"L-Lloyd?"

The faces he was welcomed to see belonged to Count and Countess Frontera, and both murmured his name in unison. Thankfully, Lloyd was able to grasp the situation right away.

So, we teleported from the cave to the Frontera manor in one flicking motion.

Truly, the magic of the dragon was impressive. Lloyd bowed toward the count and countess and said, "I am here. I must have surprised you quite a bit."

"Um... Y-yes, but... Who is that? And the lion?" Count Arcos pointed at Dragon King Verkis and the manticore.

Lloyd’s wry smile deepened. “Very important guests of ours. I will give you an explanation later. It is more important for me to hurry and escort them inside first. Excuse me for a moment, please.”

Lloyd sensed that this wasn’t the time to dawdle explaining the whole situation to them. And he was right. The look on Dragon King Verkis’s face was slowly changing as he stood beside Lloyd.

He’s signaling that he wants to go to sleep right now!

Half-shut eyes. Unfocused pupils. Drooped shoulders. Hunched back. Slow hands and legs. It looked like Verkis could sleep for a whole day right here if Lloyd put down a blanket on the dirt ground.

No. I brought the dragon king here. I have to provide him with a good place to sleep. That’s how I’ll be able to have more bargaining power in the future.

Lloyd grew impatient as he feared that Verkis might collapse to the ground right this moment. After quibbling a few words to the count and countess, Lloyd said as he nearly pushed Verkis, “Excuse me, my king?”

“Mhm...” replied Verkis dully.

“Thank you for the magic. Please follow me.”

“Must I have to follow you...” mumbled Verkis.

“Argh! Eek, no, you can’t fall asleep here!”

“I’m sleepy...”

“It’s not very far!”

Lloyd helped Verkis hurriedly as if he was helping out an injured comrade on a battlefield, almost carrying the king with his body. And then, he took Verkis to the annex building for guests and threw him onto the bed.

“Okay, then I’ll wake you up in the morning! Please sleep well!” yelled Lloyd.

Snore...

Another crisis was overcome by that. Lloyd was able to breathe in relief at last. And then he went back to the count and countess, who were still recovering from surprise at the whole event, and explained everything from the beginning.

“So...” Count Arcos gulped before continuing. “The guest a while ago... is the king of all dragons?”

“Yes, that is a precise summary,” conceded Lloyd.

“And we will be serving such a great figure? For a whole year?”

“Yes. That’s what has been decided somehow,” replied Lloyd.

“Is there any request he particularly asked of us?”

“Um, there is.”

“What is it?” Count Frontera gulped.

“We need to wake him up once a day in the morning,” answered Lloyd.

“Wake him up?”

“Yes, he told me that he needs to contact his wife, the dragon queen, every morning. As I told you a while ago, that’s how I came to bring him here.”

“Hahaha...” Count Arcos burst into laughter. Even though he tried to suppress it, he couldn’t.

How did my son grow to be so...?

Count Arcos wondered how his son had grown to be so capable. He looked at Lloyd with a gaze filled with awe. It had become commonplace for Lloyd

to be summoned by the queen for an assignment, and as if that wasn't enough, he just arrived at the manor with none other than the dragon king. Now, Lloyd held connections not only with the queen of a kingdom but also with the king of all dragons.

Perhaps, I will become a father to a son that will be remembered by history.

Such a thought flashed Count Frontera's mind. But there was one thing the count was oblivious of. Lloyd had another king in his network on top of the human queen and dragon king. It was the King of Hell. But Lloyd didn't bother to tell the count and countess about him.

I mean, it's Hell. It's quite literally the underworld. He's going to get worried if I tell him that I've been there.

On one hand, it was pretty uncomfortable to share that story. After all, Lloyd had met the real Lloyd in Hell and helped the latter stop wandering and reincarnate. Sure, he could leave out that part of the story, but doing so made him uncomfortable as if his head was being wretched with his voice of conscience. So, he decided the story about the real Lloyd should be revealed in the future. When an appropriate opportunity arose, he would bring it up. Even if it invited rebuke and resentment from the count and countess, Lloyd was determined to come clean about the whole truth.

But now's not the time for that.

First, he had a lot of work to take care of. And so, Lloyd excluded the part about his trip to Hell while he narrated the whole story to Count and Countess Frontera. And naturally, the story flowed to another subject, which was first brought up by Count Frontera, who said, "By the way, that lion... is that a new friend you have summoned like Sir Ppodong?"

Count Frontera was intrigued by the manticore that was sniffing the flowers in the garden. Lloyd smiled and said, "Oh, no, it's not that. It's a manticore, one of Dragon King Verkis loyal servants. And that is why it came along with us."

“Hmm, I see,” said both Count and Countess Frontera as they nodded without showing any other reaction. The guards, servants, maids, and villagers reacted similarly to them when they saw the manticore.

“Eh? There’s a giant lion I’ve never seen before.”

“It’s extremely big and fat!”

“It’s as big as Sir Ppodong!”

“Mom! I want to touch its belly!”

In short, the people in this region weren’t terrified by the sheer size and stateliness of the manticore. The rationale was simple. They already had plenty of experience with Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, and Bibeong. Moreover, they had endless encounters with all sorts of evil monsters during the Monster Domino incident. Bluntly put, the villagers had all been through hell and back, so in their eyes, the legendary manticore was nothing but a big, chubby lion with a pink belly or a fat cat. Regardless, the Manticore happily enjoyed the welcoming reactions of people toward it.

“Dad! I want to ride that!”

“Cororong!”

“It says you can!”

In the next few days, the manticore immediately became a fluffy ride and an insect-collecting friend for the kids of the Frontera fiefdom. While all of this was happening, Lloyd became fairly busy himself as there was a sizable pile of work for him to take care of.

There’s the water pipe that repeatedly froze and thawed throughout the winter. And I should check on the water system in the Maritz Wetland and the retaining walls in the terrace fields. We’ve accumulated a fair bit of ondol maintenance requests. Plus, the safety check for the coal mine and maintenance of the water pipes in the main sewage needs to get done. Wow. This is nuts.

He had been away for too long. Count Arcos had tried hard in his own way, as did Sir Bayern, the Engineering Corps, and the Skeleton Corps, but there was an inevitable difference in the inspection directly led by Lloyd in terms of quality and meticulousness.

Well, it's all right since I won't be going away like before anymore.

He could say goodbye to leaving the fiefdom and working for any outsiders. His days of going out of the fiefdom and earning money to save his family, protect Frontera fiefdom, and make money for retirement were over. There wasn't any need for it anymore. All of his obstacles had been overcome. Right now, what awaited Lloyd was basking in the goodness of life and lazing around for his remaining days.

And so this will be my last time putting this much effort into repair and inspection.

Down the road, maintenance would only take a little effort since he'd stay near the fiefdom. He would just need to maintain and protect his golden goose, the fiefdom. When Lloyd had this thought, the fatigue in his body disappeared, pushing him to work harder. Meanwhile, he also didn't forget to wake Verkis up every morning. It turned out that acting as an alarm for the dragon king was not an easy job.

"Um, my great king," called Lloyd.

"……."

"It's time to wake up," said Lloyd again.

Snore...

"Um, don't you need to call the dragon queen?"

"Eh... Later..." mumbled the groggy dragon king.

"Later? Do you want me to wake you up later?" replied Lloyd.

"Mhm..."

“When do you want me to wake you up?”

“Tomorrow...”

“...”

Lloyd was dumbstruck and didn’t like what the dragon king was saying. It turned out Verkis was even less of a morning fellow than Lloyd thought. So, left without any choice, he made a last-ditch effort.

Please forgive me, Dragon King Verkis. You have brought this onto yourself. Ehem! Lloyd cleared his throat and started to sing in a clear voice.

“Dear, dear Dragon King! Sleepy, sleepy Dragon King! Chicken, chicken, don’t cry! You might wake up the dragon king!”

The song was destructive. It sounded like a wake-up call from Hell. It deafened the eardrum of its listener and successfully opened the gates of Hell. It was so painful and sharp it made the listeners feel like they had acid smeared in their eardrums. As such, Dragon King Verkis became completely awake.

“Do you... want me to punch you right in the stomach and make you return to mother nature?” growled Verkis, visibly annoyed.

“Ehem! Ehem! Please forgive me,” apologized Lloyd.

“Or do you want to become a speck of dioxin in this wretched world?”

“Please, f-forgive me. But still!”

“Still?”

“I thought I should still make sure you keep your promise to call the dragon queen.”

“Tsk. Is that why you sang that awful song on purpose?”

“No,” denied Lloyd.

“Then?”

“I sang to the best of my ability.”

“That’s your best?” said Verkis in shock.

“Yes, my lord.”

“I’m sorry...”

“Ehem...”

Anyway, Lloyd managed to act as an alarm for the dragon king every morning. Soon, he was able to attain certainty.

Finally, I really did it.

He really did everything. His goal was to spend the rest of his life in a peaceful province without any hard work or complicated affairs. This was the reason why Lloyd worked so hard and overcame countless obstacles. At times, he felt hopeless but always jumped back on his feet again. He breathlessly raced forward without giving up, and finally, he achieved the goal.

The fiefdom was absolutely safe and held heaps of capital. He had no more future concerns. And the truth about the real Lloyd would be revealed to the count and countess soon. After clearing the emotional debt he owed to them, there would be no more storms to break through. Lloyd was dwelling on these thoughts in this bedroom. And now, he took a deep breath. It was late at night, with no one to call for him. He composed his heart amid the tranquility.

This will be the last time I check.

He had achieved everything he wanted in life. There was nothing to worry about anymore. Would he really be able to die in peace after living a life of relaxation? Or would there be more unexpected events and incidents? Lloyd opened the skill window to check his future and activated a skill he hadn’t used in a while.

Clack.

[Skill Name: Ending Spoiler]

[Skill Feature: Absolute Authority]

[Required CP: 80 (Third)]

[You can take a peek at the portion of the ending scene that will unfold in this story by spending some of CP. It may have a happy or sad ending.]

The familiar skill description spanned. Lloyd took a deep breath.

Let's take a look.

Lloyd selected the activate button at the bottom of the skill window.

[Skill Name: Would you like to use the Ending Spoiler?]

[Required RP: 80 (Third)]

[Current CP: 1,192]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a YES.

Ding dong.

[Skill Name: Ending Spoiler has been activated.]

[You have used 80 CP.]

[Current CP: 1,112]

The skill activation message cascaded in front of him. From then on...

Crackle...! Time around him terribly slowed until it finally stopped. The window curtain swaying against the spring wind, the flower petals blowing in the air all stopped as though they were pegged in a wall called time. And just like it always did, the space ahead of Lloyd swayed until it opened a round blue passage.

Let's go.

Lloyd walked into the passage, and everything in his vision was enveloped by light.

Fwoosh! Lloyd cast his glance at the new scenery spanning in front of him. And then he was appalled by what he saw.

What... is this?

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Chapter 251: Third Ending Spoiler (1)

What... is this?

Lloyd tightened the muscles around his eyes to open them wide but failed. It was obvious why he couldn’t do it. He was watching the ending spoiler for himself, and only his consciousness entered his body nearing its death. As such, he couldn’t freely move his future body. He was merely a direct observer, watching the future unfold before his eyes.

His gaze landed on an old note, the cover of which was unfamiliar, titled “The Records of Lloyd Frontera.” It was a journal.

I’m keeping a journal?

Lloyd curiously tilted his head in wonder as he had never had a habit of journaling. The only times he jotted down in a diary were when his elementary school teacher gave it as an assignment and when he was forced to keep one in the army.

That hasn’t changed. I don’t journal.

Could it be that he picked up the habit in the future? How accustomed could he have become that he would continue to do it in the face of death?

Still, I don’t think this is a bad thing.

Lloyd chuckled. He was surprised at first at the unexpected scene. But on second thought, this wasn’t a bad sight to see. He actually quite liked what he saw.

The fact I’d keep a journal just goes to show how relaxed and sweet my life must have become.

He must have been stuck in a groove. Bored. That must be how peaceful and problem-free his life was. Otherwise, there was no chance he’d cultivate a journaling habit. Lloyd felt relieved at that thought. But that

relief was short-lived, cracked and interrupted by a cough from his future self.

Cough! Cough! Spurt! Lloyd erupted into a terrible coughing fit, drops of dark blood splattering onto his diary. He raised his quivering hand and wiped them off the paper with his ragged and muddied sleeve.

Eh? Hold on.

Lloyd's heart sank.

What's wrong with my sleeve?

His gaze hurried toward his sleeve, wiping the blood off his journal. It was originally a brightly colored shirt, but now, it was covered in gray and yellow stains, making him wonder when it was last washed. Plus, the fabric was completely frayed and the button on it had long fallen off.

What the heck? Why do my clothes look like this when I should be living a comfortable life?

Something was wrong. His heart started to pound. He didn't want to believe it, but a sense of nervousness started to grip him, and his gaze hurried once more.

Hold on. What about my hand?

Just then, he recalled the second time he used the Ending Spoiler option. Since he was only an observer who peeked through the future with the eyes of his future self, Lloyd couldn't get a good look at his appearance unless he was standing in front of a mirror. As such, the most convenient method for him to check his age was by looking at his hands.

A-and my hands?

Lloyd looked down at his hands inside the sleeves. And his heart sank once again.

I have no... wrinkles.

His hands were smooth. They were slightly rough but had no wrinkles. He couldn’t spot any dark spots that came with old age either.

So, I’m not dying of old age. What is going on here?

Nervous, Lloyd decided to keep watching and observe the situation. Meanwhile, his future self picked up a pen once he stopped coughing and opened his journal with trembling hands. This moment granted Lloyd the opportunity to peek at the writing inside.

Flip.

[This is the first time I have chosen to write in a journal. I am sad. The count got into an accident. He was simply enjoying horseback riding like usual. He was riding through a path he often enjoyed taking. Who would’ve imagined that a weasel would appear and surprise the horse into suddenly jumping? Who would’ve imagined the count would fall off and hit a tree branch on the neck? The physician says we should wait and see, but... I’m not so sure. I’m just sad.]

Flip.

[The count woke up after a day. He says he can’t feel anything below his neck. But he forced a smile and tried to calm everyone down. He said that he was fine. That it doesn’t hurt because he can’t feel anything. That he’s comfortable since he’s on his back all day. He flashed a bright smile. And those were his last words. Right now, the countess is quietly weeping in secret. To be honest, I want to cry too. However, I should go out and comfort her first.]

Lloyd glanced at the journal, feeling utterly incredulous. The pages of his journal turned one after another.

[The countess doesn’t talk anymore. She doesn’t say a word. She no longer smiles and tends to her garden. I picked up the trowel for her lest the overlooked flowers wilt. I hope the freesias bloom beautifully this year and lessen her grief.]

Flip.

[The freesias have bloomed pretty. But the countess can’t see them. In the morning, I knew that something was wrong when I heard Emily scream. No one would have thought that the kitchen once filled with everyone’s laughter would be where she passed. No one knew until last night. Could it be that she missed the count, who passed away before her? I must call Julian. He should be in the capital. Now, our manor, once warm, feels cold and desolate.]

Flip.

[Julian isn’t responding to me. I can’t arrange the funeral for the countess until he arrives. I suppose he’s hurrying back home now instead of spending time sending me a response like he did when the count fell ill. I sent Ggoming, so he should be here soon. That’s what I hope at least.]

Flip.

[There’s a response. But it was bad news. Not from Julian. But by Sheherazade. She wailed that she shouldn’t have left the house. That she shouldn’t have left Julian alone. She said she never knew robbers would break in. No, had she gone home earlier, she’d have found him and taken him for treatment. Her letter breaking the bad news was filled with guilt and resentment. I feel numb. I can’t believe it. Julian was stabbed by a robber when he was alone in his house. This feels like a lie. I hope it’s all a lie.]

Flip.

[I don’t even know what I’ve been doing for the last month. In all honesty, I still feel numb. But I’m forcing myself to pick up a pen to leave a record of what is happening. After I held a funeral for the countess, I went to the capital and held a funeral for Julian as well. I wonder if I’ve become desensitized after going through a series of sad and tragic events. I don’t know. Now, this whole thing feels strange. The death of the count and countess, followed by Julian’s death. Is it weird that I think these situations are very similar to the novel? Something feels wrong. I’m nervous.]

What the heck? What is this?

Lloyd gritted his teeth, his gaze moving faster. He struggled to catch every word in the pages that slowly flipped one after another.

[It looks like the ominous feeling I had wasn't baseless. I received a call from the royal palace. So I went and had an audience with the queen, but something felt wrong. Something was unnatural about the way she moved her left arm. After sending everyone away, I asked her carefully if there was something wrong with her left arm. She smiled bitterly, which confirmed my suspicions. Then I was hit with something at that very moment. *The Knight of Blood and Iron.* The attempt to assassinate the queen. The arm that had been sliced off was her left arm.]

Flip.

[I'm now in the fiefdom. It's been a while. I tirelessly comforted Sheherazade while I was in the capital. I had a feeling that something would happen to her as well if my hunch was right. I pray that nothing will happen to her. I sincerely hope that my hunch is wrong.]

Flip.

[My heart is heavy. Shiloh and Meatloaf. The loan sharks that burdened my family. I received news that they've been murdered. A small scuffle went wrong, and they got stabbed in the neck. My heart sank when I heard the news. The count and countess. Julian. The two loan sharks. All of them were the people that died in the early part of the novel.]

Flip.

[The last few months have been a nervous ride. Thankfully, there weren't any other major incidents or mishaps. But I feel desolate and nervous. I keep thinking about drinking these days. I shouldn't act like this.]

Flip.

[A war broke out in the south. It’s nothing big—just a regional war. Well, that probably isn’t something I need to worry about. I should send a letter to Sheherazade and suggest that she move here.]

Flip.

[I haven’t received a response from her. Something’s off. I’m nervous.]

Flip.

[I received news about her. A notice stating that Sheherazade was killed in action. That was only when I was able to learn what happened. It turns out she volunteered for the war in the south the moment it broke out. Was it to vent off her steam after losing Julian? It’s said that Sheherazade recklessly charged ahead at the very frontline. At one point, she was desperately fighting after becoming isolated in enemy territory. That was said to be the last time she was seen. Now... I don’t know. The destinies I’ve changed with my hard work while living in this world. And the people who were able to avoid death because of my efforts. Each and every one of them is leaving my side one by one.]

Dammit.

Lloyd shivered in shock, but the pages kept flipping with more news of death. The sultan’s death after accidentally falling off from a height at a festival. Orc Arosh’s whole body became paralyzed from getting injured during a hunt. Even Lady Namaran, the leader of the Namaran fiefdom, got into an accident. She slipped on a busy city road with a steep slope and got crushed under a carriage. Her death was instantaneous.

What is this? Is fate pulling a prank on us?

Lloyd was dumbstruck. Did all of these things really happen? They were unbelievable, dumbfounding, and also disturbing at the same time. This was as he could see there was a commonality between all the incidents.

All of them die or get into an accident in the novel, but their destinies changed when I stepped into this world and saved them.

But every single one of them died similarly to the story in the novel.

What about me?

Just then, he remembered how Lloyd died in the novel. He became terribly sick from his heavy drinking and died in the corner of a pub, coughing out blood.

It can't be.

Now, the journal was on its last page. Lloyd's heart tensed as he looked at it. Meanwhile, at last, the future Lloyd shakily moved his hand to painstakingly fill up the last page with crooked letters.

[Now, I don't know. I don't know how this happened. Should I have stayed away from alcohol? No, I failed to protect anyone. The pain was unbearable. Now, I just want to... rest. I don't know about a life of luxury anymore. My extra life? That turned out to be real. I came back alive a few days ago, but look at me now. Everything's a struggle. I'm fatigued and worn out. It seems that fate isn't something you can escape after all. What was it all for? I am really...]

At that moment...

"Cough...! Argh! Gargh! Arggh!"

His whole body convulsed vehemently as he wrote. He coughed like he was about to spit out his soul. But instead of his soul, something else shot out. *Spurt!*

'...!'

Blood. A flood of dark blood came out of his mouth. It covered the entire page of the journal he was writing in.

Crash! Then he fell off the chair, and it was only then that the present Lloyd was able to see the room. It was a familiar place. A shabby room on the second floor of a bar in the fiefdom.

“Master Lloyd!”

Someone rushed into the room, and his silver hair was visible in between Lloyd’s fading vision.

“Javi...er.”

Javier’s panicked gestures toward him. That was the end.

Fwoosh! Everything darkened, and Lloyd felt his body float in the air for a moment. And he opened his eyes.

“...”

Swish. The curtain that had been frozen in place resumed swaying against the night air. That sight gave Lloyd a slight shiver. It was only when he turned and saw the window that he realized what happened.

I’m back.

The Ending Spoiler was over, and he was in his bedroom at the present time. But his heart continued to pound, refusing to calm down.

What did I just see?

He couldn’t believe it. But at the same time, he had to believe it.

The Ending Spoiler had never lied to him before. It was all thanks to this skill option that he could block the locust swarm’s attack during the Monster Domino incident and prevent a cholera outbreak when the fiefdom saw an influx of refugees coming in. So what he saw had to be true this time as well. Lloyd began falling into despair.

Those incidents weren’t merely coincidental.

Seated on the edge of the bed, Lloyd struggled to calm his breath while organizing his thoughts on the future events he read about in the journal.

I only saw a glimpse of it, but the count gets injured while horse-riding three years from now.

That marked the beginning of incidents. At first, Lloyd thought of it as an unfortunate accident, but that proved to be false as he continued reading the journal.

It can't be a coincidence. What I read was far too sinister to just be mere accidents. Only those who were supposed to die in the novel but got saved by me started to die. As if someone cherry-picked them.

Worse, their manner of death shown in the Ending Spoiler was almost identical to the way they died in the original novel. It was the same case with Queen Magentano, whose left arm became paralyzed for an inexplicable reason.

While she loses an arm in the novel, her arm gets paralyzed here.

Given that the queen was a sword master, a paralyzed arm was the same as not having one. And what about him?

Those series of events sent me into a state of depression and made me look for alcohol. Then I got sick until I died wretchedly in the corner of a bar...

He died while vomiting a flood of blood from his mouth. Ultimately, he was set to meet the same ending as the character Lloyd Frontera.

Shoot. This is unbelievable.

Lloyd couldn't help but curse. Could it be that fate was playing a joke on him? Or did this mean that fate wasn't something he could change in the end? If so, was this an issue that couldn't be solved at all?

No, I don't think that's the case.

Lloyd shook his head. Whether this was a cruel joke from fate or an inescapable reality, he figured that he had to try something first. It would be much too regrettable for him to give up so early.

Duh! I've worked hard to get where I am now!

It was only now that he had finally obtained everything he needed for a life of abundance and was ready to happily live in peace with the resources he collected one by one. But to think he would go through those cursed events. That wasn't something he wanted. If this was how the story was meant to end, Lloyd wanted to grab the author by the collar and pummel him to the ground. And so...

There must be a cause that brings about this scandalous catastrophe. Whether it be destiny or anything else. There has to be a way I can alter or prevent it.

Lloyd pondered. The simplest solution would be to prevent the count from falling off his horse, which was the start of everything. But he shook his head.

No. No matter how I look at it, this isn't just an unfortunate incident. So, that alone will not be enough. Something else will happen to the count even if I stop this one incident. In the end, a series of similar accidents will keep happening one after another.

What if these accidents were the price he had to pay for going against fate? What if fate was interfering now to lead all the events of this world to the original storyline? In other words, Lloyd thought that simply preventing the next incident from occurring wouldn't be enough.

Of course, it could be a simple accident. But what if it isn't? What if something horrible happens due to my lack of preparation? Then it's over. I have to do something. First, I should expect the worst and find the root cause of the situation.

Lloyd reached that conclusion. The answer was simple. He had to find the root cause of all the incidents.

I don't have much time.

Lloyd jumped out of bed and walked into the corridor in the middle of the night. At the same time, a thought started to form in his head. If all the events that took place until now were to overcome the threats toward the Frontera family, from now on, he was embarking on a journey to change his own destiny. Even so, however, he wasn't discouraged.

What else can I do? I just have to go through with it.

Just like a mountain of assignments given by a merciless professor, this couldn't be avoided. It was much like his days in the past when he had to work to make a living while completing all his school assignments. If there was something he had to face and get done, there was one move he made before anything else.

Let's cut down on my sleep first.

Lloyd opted for the simplest and most standard decision he made during the roughest periods of life. If he had homework to finish or if he had to work part-time but lacked time, sacrificing his sleep was the only option. He could gain more time by pulling an all-nighter. From then on, much like the desperate days of his past, Lloyd started to burn the midnight oil in his study. Of course, he grumbled and complained about his life the entire time.

Crap! I wish there was Internet here!

To change the cursed future he got a glimpse of through the Ending Spoiler, Lloyd embarked on a laborious endeavor to search for a solution to change his tragic destiny.

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Chapter 252: Third Ending Spoiler (2)

Internet, the gigantic network that covered the entire world. It was a convenience that everyone in the 21st century enjoyed, much like breathing. Even at this very moment, there were probably countless people casually opening their laptops or using their smartphones. Some would be doing so to work, to study, or even to just kill time and have fun. The internet was as vast as the Pacific Ocean, storing millions of pieces of information. At any time, it had the power to draw in countless people while unknowingly making them develop turtleneck syndrome. That was what the Internet was. And now, there was one man in the Frontera study who wretchedly missed this convenience of modern civilization on Earth.

“Argh...” Lloyd groaned at length as he rested his chin in his hands, at the same time mechanically opening another book. He lost count of how many books he had read but was sure it was over a hundred.

This is nuts, really.

Lloyd shook his head hard in an effort to shake off his drowsiness. And then he glanced at the pile of books next to him and let out a sigh.

I’ve stayed up all night for the past four days, and there’s still so much left to read.

He seemed to have around 50 more books to read through. Most of them were philosophical books on fate and magic. Some even dealt with astrology, astronomy, spirits, myths, and regional folklore. What was he doing now? Lloyd was devouring every book that could give him a clue to the future he had glimpsed through the Ending Spoiler.

But it’s not like I can skim them.

Indeed he couldn’t. In all honesty, he wanted to roughly skim through all the pages, which was impossible. These books were different from modern South Korean books, which were neatly designed and arranged in clear paragraphs and pages. Back home, writings with poor readability were

rejected by customers and didn’t make any sales, whether it was an essay, self-help book, or magazine. And so, every book was designed to provide a hassle-free reading experience.

But the books of this world were very inconsiderate and far from being readable. Since there was no advanced printing technology, the books were transcribed by hand. Some of them were even written in such a tiny font that Lloyd had to use magnifying glasses.

These books are totally inconsiderate of their readers!

What was more, all the books dealt with new topics for him, so he feared that he’d miss a vital piece of information if he skimmed through them. He was practically forced to carefully study all the materials. It was an exhausting job.

Internet. I need the Internet.

Lloyd missed this modern convenience he once enjoyed in South Korea. What would it have been like if the Lorasian Continent had the internet? He would have been able to search up the destiny he had changed and the series of accidents that followed afterward. Or, at least, he would have been able to ask questions on an online forum.

That would have been a thousand times better than burying myself in books for four days straight. I’d have gotten more information or clues about what I wanted to know.

Thump. Lloyd closed the book. He lifted his head, feeling numb.

I know I like to punish myself, but this won’t do.

Ransacking books to find a clue for the explanation behind everyone’s impending misfortunes, which he foresaw through the Ending Spoiler, appeared unwise. He became surer of it when he thought about the internet search system on Earth.

Working my fingers to the bone isn't going to cut it. It'd just be a waste of time.

That was his conclusion after spending four stressful days of research. The reason was simple.

One. There are too many books, and I don't know what information they will hold. So I have to manually read through all of them one by one. But that has proved to be a slow process and takes an absurd amount of time.

Lloyd had spent four whole days stuck in the library except for the times he went outside to wake Verkis. He even tried his surveying skill to see if it worked here, but it didn't. The skill could only find the thickness and width of the paper pages, not the content of the books. As such, he got to work doing nothing but reading for four days straight. However, he was only able to get through about 100 books despite his efforts.

And if I continue what I'm doing now... How much more time will I need?

And what if he continued spending his days reading? It would take 30 days to go through 1,000 books and 300 days to read 10,000 books.

By then, I'd have browsed through all of the relevant materials available in the Central Library in the palace.

But Lloyd was skeptical about investing 300 days in this task.

Will I be able to find key information by spending 300 days reading every single book in the Central Library?

He wasn't sure. What if he found nothing? Then he'd be wasting 300 precious days.

Even if I find any relevant resources or information, there's another problem.

There was more he needed to do on top of looking for relevant resources and information. He had to collect and analyze the gathered materials and

cross-check whether the conclusion drawn from them was right. It was only then that he would be able to come up with a solution.

That's the problem. I don't have enough time.

Lloyd recalled the journal he saw through the Ending Spoiler. The count's horseback riding accident was the very first mishap. And that's only three years from now.

I would need to find relevant materials, analyze them, and draw a conclusion. Three years will pass by in a flash while I go through all these steps. That won't do. By the time I have a solution, the accident would have already happened. It'd be too late.

Lloyd shook his head. When he did the math, the answer became clear to him. He would waste far too much time searching for information in books.

I need another method that doesn't require me to go through everything by hand. Oh, how I wish I had access to the internet—the place where I can upload questions for knowledgeable people to answer. It's so convenient.

Wait a second. There is a god-like being who has the answer to everything here too!

Lloyd stopped as he sighed, his eyes flying open. That was right. Come to think of it, there was one. Moreover, they were very close by!

The Dragon King!

Lloyd jumped to his feet.

I was an idiot! I hadn't considered that this entire time. The Dragon King may know something about those incidents.

A possibility appeared, and come to think of it, there was someone else other than Verkis who could possibly answer his questions.

And if I can't get any satisfactory answer from the Dragon King... Then I should ask the King of Hell.

He knew his way to Hell. The Hell gate was still open in the northern region, and he could enter and fly right toward the Hell Castle.

Though, of course, I'll have to pay a fair price to hear a response from the King of Hell.

It was possible the king would demand a fairly high price. So Lloyd decided to ask Verkis first since the latter wouldn't demand payment. Furthermore, it was the perfect time to do so as the sun was about to rise soon.

Afterward, Lloyd took a short nap, resting his head against a book he was reading. Soon, when the sun rose, he jumped up and hurried to the annex, where he woke Verkis as usual. "Um, my king, it's time to wake up."

"Ah..." mumbled Verkis sleepily.

"I will start singing if you don't wake up."

"Hey, I'm awake."

"Congratulations," said Lloyd, "You woke up right away."

Yawn. Verkis half-opened his groggy eyes, still heavy with sleep. And he drew a magic circle in the air and tried to connect to his wife. But the result was the same as the previous day.

Bzzt!

"Ha..."

The same today. She rejected his call. It looked like she was still upset. Thinking she would eventually come around as long as he kept trying, he lay back on the bed.

In any case, I'm done for the day!

The thought excited him. He covered himself with the blanket with an excited heart, but something strange happened.

“Hey... Why are you still here?” Verkis muttered.

Strangely, unlike usual, Lloyd was still in his room. Normally, the man would quietly leave after saying he would return again the next day while Verkis prepared to fall back asleep. But today, he wasn’t doing that. Instead, he was looking at him with a strange gaze.

“Hey, what are you doing?” blurted Verkis again. “Why are you staring at me with a pleading face?”

“Um, may I ask you something?” said Lloyd at last.

“No, you can’t.”

“...”

“I’m off to sleep.” *Snore!*

“...”

Verkis fell back asleep right after he finished talking. Dumbstruck, Lloyd tried to wake the king but failed. He even audaciously poked the king’s shoulder, danced, and sang like a nutcase. Verkis was unperturbed. However, Lloyd wasn’t willing to give up so easily.

I can’t give up! If I can’t get an answer here, I have to travel all the way down to Hell.

He was hesitant about traveling down to Hell, particularly as Hellkaros wasn’t the type to do anything for free. Lloyd could be forced to pay a huge sum of money to obtain a single piece of information.

If possible, it’d be best if I can get help from the dragon king.

From that morning on, a match began between Lloyd and Verkis.

“Dragon King Verkis!” yelled Lloyd. “I have a question for you!”

“Sure, see you tomorrow.” *Snore!*

“...”

Verkis happily went back to sleep. And each morning, every time he woke the dragon king, Lloyd persistently asked him a question, never giving up.

“Dragon King Verkis!” yelled Lloyd. “Does altering the original path of fate influence the present time?”

“I have no clue. See you tomorrow.” *Snore!*

“...”

His question was ignored once again. Regardless, a new day began the next morning.

“Dragon King Verkis!” yelled Lloyd. “I’ve come from another dimension and somehow ended up changing the fate of this world!”

“Oh, did you?” whispered Verkis.

“Yes!”

“All right. See you tomorrow.” *Snore!*

“...”

A new day arrived once again.

“Dragon King Verkis!” yelled Lloyd. “I’ve learned that tragedy will strike, and all the people who were supposed to be dead in the original novel but survived because of me will be killed!”

“I see. You are very impressive.”

“Thank you so much!”

“Okay. See you tomorrow then.” *Snore!*

“...”

As expected, the next morning came soon enough.

“Dragon King Verkis!” yelled Lloyd. “Do you remember the questions I’ve been asking you?”

“No, I don’t. See you tomorrow.” *Snore!*

“...”

And the sun rose each day without fail.

“Dragon King Verkis!” begged Lloyd. “Please give me an answer now!”

“I don’t want to. I’m sleeping. See you tomorrow.” *Snore!*

“...”

Nature brought yet another morning again.

“Dragon King Verkis!” bawled Lloyd. “If you don’t give me an answer today, then I’ll wake you up with a kiss!”

“You have finally lost it,” Verkis replied as his eyes grew wide.

“Yes, I have!”

“...”

“So could you answer my question please?” begged Lloyd.

“Hm, no. I don’t plan on giving you an answer. Go away now.”

“But you’ve just answered a question from me!”

Lloyd glued himself to the side of the bed and pitifully stared at Verkis in desperation. Verkis was shocked.

Should I kill him?

Verkis considered it for a second and wondered if Lloyd had truly lost it. But he decided not to kill him and sighed at length.

I shouldn't kill him. I'm supposed to receive help from him. I said I'd stay in this fiefdom in return for him waking me up every morning. It was a promise I made.

He couldn't break it. What would happen if he went back on his word? He would risk losing his power as a dragon.

I can't kill him. Should I just shut his mouth with magic? No. Then he won't be able to wake me up properly. Tsk. This is bothersome.

Verkis was extremely bothered by Lloyd, who had been throwing weird questions at him for the past few days. He couldn't get any peskier. But at the same time, Verkis couldn't ignore him indefinitely as it was obvious that Lloyd was hellbent on badgering him without giving up.

I'll just tell him whatever comes to my mind.

Verkis finally figured that Lloyd would eventually call it quits to his incessant questions then. That seemed to be a better scenario. Having reached such a conclusion, Verkis asked, "So you're from another dimension?"

"Yes, I am."

"And this world was a novel in your dimension?"

"Yes, I am telling the truth."

"Okay. You don't need to convince me. In the first place, the dimension you're from is nothing but a piece of hard drive saved in a storage of another dimension."

"Excuse me...?"

"What are you getting surprised for? That's the way it is with dimensions. Anyway, to sum up your questions, you came from another dimension, and

you’ve altered the original destiny of this world. Am I right?”

“Yes, my lord.”

“However, the people you saved in that process will all lose their lives at some point in the future. And you want to prevent that from happening. Right?”

“Yes. That is exactly what I mean.”

“Then it’s simple,” Verkis smirked. “Have you ever heard of the phenomenon called ‘The Restoration of Destiny’?”

Even the Dragon King surrendered to Lloyd’s persistence, which had at last earned Llyod a reward equal to getting a question answered on an online forum.

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Chapter 253: The Restoration Force of Destiny (1)

Altering the path of fate was not an easy task. No, it was almost impossible. Like an overly tight bowstring, no matter how much you attempted to yank and stretch it to change its shape, it returned to its original form as soon as you let your hands go.

“That is the phenomenon called the restoration of destiny,” explained Verkis dully. “That is how tenacious destiny is. And its restoration power is formidable.”

“Is that what it is?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes.” Verkis nodded before elaborating, “For some inexplicable reason, there are rare instances where the path of destiny goes through a drastic change due to external interference like yourself. And destiny exerts great force to restore its original flow of events.”

“So it strives to go back to the way things were supposed to happen.” Lloyd’s face darkened.

“That’s right,” affirmed Verkis. “Did you say in the novel you read, the count, no, the baron and baroness hang themselves due to their crippling debt?”

“Yes...” Lloyd nodded heavily. The baron and the baroness’s death were appallingly similar to the manner in which his parents passed away, the very tragic incident Lloyd never wanted to see but witnessed with his own eyes.

Verkis crinkled his brows slightly. “And you were able to save them with immense effort, only for the count to fall off a horse and break his neck. Furthermore, this also causes the countess to end her own life in grief. That’s the phenomenon of the restoration of destiny. You won’t be able to easily stop these incidents from happening. No, it will be almost impossible to make any changes.”

“Even if I prevent the count from falling off the horse?” Lloyd’s voice sounded more desperate.

“Mhm. You may stop this one incident, but the baron will keep finding himself in absurd situations. For example, he might slip from the tub after that day and break his neck there.”

“...”

“That’s the way things are. You could go out of your way and do everything possible to prevent these incidents, but eventually, everyone will face their original destiny.”

“Then what am I supposed to do to stop destiny?” Lloyd felt dizzy as he heard these words.

“I don’t know,” blurted Verkis nonchalantly.

“Excuse me?” Lloyd’s brow lifted.

“Didn’t you hear me? I don’t know.”

“Wow.” Lloyd gaped.

“How am I supposed to know that? Do I look like a god?”

“But-”

“Are you trying to complain about why I bothered to rattle on about destiny and its restoration when I didn’t have an answer for your question?” accused Verkis with a stinging gaze.

“Yes.”

“Tsk, you don’t even deny it.”

“I am being honest, my lord.”

“Well, but I might have an idea that could work.”

“My lord,” called Lloyd, suddenly changing his attitude. “I’ve truly admired you for a very long time now.”

“...”

“I am being sincere.”

“Ha... Anyway, I don’t know if it’s going to be the solution to the restoration of destiny, but it might offer you a clue. Have you ever heard of the Jewel of Truth from the Mermaid Kingdom?”

“No, I haven’t.” Lloyd shook his head. The Jewel of Truth? He had never heard of it. The novel didn’t mention it, either.

“I heard this,” continued Verkis, “from a mermaid I knew a very long time ago. I was told about something called the Jewel of Truth in the Mermaid Kingdom.”

“Is it possibly something that reveals the truths about this world?”

“Mhm. Something like that. More specifically, it only answers one question.”

“Only one question?”

“Yes. Just one.” Verkis lifted his index finger. “It gives the truth to any question you ask. But here’s the catch. Your question needs to be extremely specific to get an answer.”

“Then...” Lloyd rolled his eyes, pausing and thinking for a second. “If I ask it to tell me how I can stop the restoration of destiny from occurring around me, would that be a specific question?”

“Probably? You will find it out once you get to the Mermaid Kingdom.”

“All right. Then how do I get there?” Lloyd’s voice slightly shook. It was done. He finally found a clue. At one point, he had even fantasized about using the internet in all of his desperation! But now, after poking around, he finally got a useful answer from the Dragon King!

The Jewel of Truth in the Mermaid Kingdom. He's saying I have to go to the Mermaid Kingdom to find that, right?

Hope was rising above the horizon. A vision of hope appeared in his head. He thought that he might be able to resolve this matter much more easily than he expected. That was until he heard Verkis's next words, which shattered his hope to pieces.

"I don't know."

"Excuse me?" Lloyd's brow lifted in dismay.

"I don't know where the Mermaid Kingdom is."

"But you just said you have a mermaid friend-"

"Oh, she died of old age."

"..."

"What was her name? Houhora? That woman used to be the queen of the kingdom. But she died of old age."

"Wait, but you must have kept in touch with her until she passed away."

"We did. Though I mostly just used her to do my work."

"..."

"But that was until she became the queen. She changed the kingdom's location and never told me what it was."

"..."

My Dragon King Verkis! What kind of interpersonal relationship did you have, you sleepyhead? Lloyd wanted to heave a sigh. Lloyd sensed that this was all that he could get from Verkis. The latter didn't know, so what could Lloyd do?

I should back off at this point.

It would be crossing the line to cling to Verkis right now. And sure enough, his eyes were now heavy with sleep.

Okay. I've gotten enough information. It'll only hurt me if I excessively bother him.

One had to know when to step back after they obtained what they wanted. Now was the time, Lloyd sensed. He plastered a smile of a service worker on his face.

"I see. Anyway, thank you. My Dragon King, no, my hero, I sincerely thank you."

"Your hero?" Verkis repeated.

"Oh my, my true thoughts accidentally slipped out-"

"Leaving aside if you're being sincere or not, does this mean that you'll be off to search for the Mermaid Kingdom?"

"It looks like I will be," replied Lloyd.

"Then what about my wake-up call?" Verkis shot back.

"I will turn over that job to one of my subordinates."

"Really? Are any of your subordinates capable of waking me up as well as you?" asked Verkis incredulously.

"Yes, though they can't speak." Lloyd smiled as he thought of the members of the Skeleton Corps.

Turtle Neck, Square Jaw, and Frozen Shoulder. You're going to wake up even if you don't want to when they come here, tap, hula dance, and every morning.

Their bones would crack and creak, and the noise of their breathless dancing would force Verkis up, even if he was the dragon king. Thanks to these folks, Lloyd was able to leave Verkis rest assured.

“You will be properly woken up every morning without a doubt. You have nothing to worry about.”

“Well, if you say so.” Verkis then sprawled on the bed. A satisfied smile hung on his face.

Great. He finally got off my back. What a pesky little fellow.

The past few days came to his mind. How cumbersome this Lloyd Frontera, no, Suho Kim, from another dimension was! As a result, Verkis had to waste a few more minutes being awake even after he was done with his morning duty. He endured the pain of not being able to sleep as soon as he could for several days. That was the reason why he told Lloyd the story of the Jewel of Truth in the Mermaid Kingdom.

Well, if he’s lucky, he’ll find it. He won’t bother me until then, at least.

Just then, an event from hundreds of years ago came to his mind. If he remembered correctly, it was the mermaid Houhorah who told him about the legend in the Mermaid Kingdom.

It was the story about the Jewel of Truth. She said she wasn’t sure whether it really existed because it emerged only once in the far distant past. It made her wonder if it was just a legend or folktale.

So the item was only mentioned briefly as if it was a silly joke. In other words, it was unidentifiable even among the mermaids in the kingdom. Its Korean equivalent would be the Dangun legend of a bear eating garlic and mugwort until it became a human woman.

Lloyd will have a hellish time trying to find the jewel. Even if he can find it, it’s going to take him a long, long time.

The corners of Verkis's lips rolled up maliciously. He wouldn't be bothered by Lloyd as long as the latter was off to locate the jewel. Verkis figured that he would eventually stop needing to call his wife every morning at some point while Lloyd was away.

If so, I'll return back to my cave. There will be no reason to see that human or listen to his whining anymore. This is perfect.

The thought satisfied Verkis to the point that his toes under his blanket wiggled on their own in happiness. Verkis was happy at these thoughts of his, while Lloyd was happy that he had obtained a clue. Both smiled.

Haah, what an annoying fellow.

Haah, what a sleepyhead.

After that, Lloyd left the room, leaving behind the snoring Dragon King, and went to his study to find the location of the Mermaid Kingdom.

I read about it a few days ago.

Lloyd picked up the book of myths and legends once he got back. It was one of the books he had studied a few days earlier as he pulled the all-nighters.

I think I saw something about the kingdom somewhere here. Mermaid... The Mermaid Kingdom... Okay. Here it is.

Thankfully, Lloyd was able to find it quickly.

[Mermaids can dive into even the deepest and roughest part of the sea, and they hide their kingdom with their power in a nearly unreachable place. As such, generally speaking, no one knows where their kingdom sits, and only clues about its whereabouts can be obtained through the words of a few seasoned sailors who voyage through the most violent seas...]

Hmm...

Lloyd rested his chin in his hand, thinking.

The most violent seas?

Lloyd searched his memory. There were countless places mentioned in the novel. Some of them being in oceans and other similar locations. He pieced together, analyzed, and compared this information in his head. Thankfully, he was able to make a conclusion quite easily.

It must be in the north.

Lloyd was certain that it was. For starters, it definitely wasn't in the south. Though quite a large sea sat in the south, it was occupied by a huge continent much like the one on Earth.

The Arctic Ocean is said to have the most violent waters in the Lorasian Continent.

It was the most dangerous and violent ocean on the continent, having waves that sometimes reached over 300 feet in height. He heard that icebergs floated along the terrifying body of water, and this particular ocean was a true nightmare for sailors.

But I was also told there are a few masochists who sail through these violent waters on purpose.

Those individuals in question were whalers hunting for emperor whales. Anyone who caught even one whale would be able to boast about it for the rest of their life. And so, it was rumored that the whalers were hoping to become rich overnight through this method.

And I'm familiar with the home port of the whaling ships.

Their home port was Port Cremo, the place where he had defeated the Gigatitan. From then on, he hurried to leave for the port. The travel preparation was simple. He just had to pack three days' worth of food for his flight to Ggoming and some equipment for sleep, such as a tent and sleeping bag. Of course, he still had the task of convincing the count and countess aside from everything else.

“What? You will be visiting Port Cremo?”

“Yes.”

Clack. Lloyd shared his plan at the dinner table, joined by the count and countess. But, of course, he wasn’t entirely frank about the whole thing. He simply cooked up an excuse that he had to visit Port Cremo for research as he had a new business idea in mind.

Count Frontera looked slightly worried as he heard Lloyd. “But are you sure that will be all right?”

“Come again?”

“You have just come back from the capital. Did you not say then that you were going to take a long break for a while at home?”

“Yes, I did,” Lloyd replied.

“That’s the reason I am worried, Lloyd,” said Count Arcos. “I understand you are a hard-working man, but what is this talk about a new business all of a sudden? Did something happen that you can’t talk to me, your father, about?”

“Oh, no, that’s not it.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd smiled as he ate a forkful of salad. He could faintly feel the concern Count and Countess Frontera had for him. He could feel that he failed to lift the weight of concern from their shoulders.

Well. I wouldn’t believe myself, either. I must look like I’m rushing things for a reason that hasn’t been mentioned.

But Lloyd had no choice right now. Time was too precious for him to spend it lazing around. He had three years before the count got into an accident.

Before that happened, he had to find a way to stop destiny from becoming restored to its original course.

So, please trust me, even though you may be worried right now.

Eventually, both of them pretended to trust Lloyd's cursory response. But they still gazed at Lloyd with concern in their eyes. Lloyd looked at them with warmth in his eyes. He was grateful for them. He wanted to protect them no matter what. It wasn't because he was afraid of being left alone in this world or because he needed them to live a comfortable life. Sure, it could've been like that a long time ago. But now, it wasn't the case, more so after he had helped the real Lloyd reincarnate.

After all, there is something I must reveal to you.

Lloyd vowed that he would come clean in the future someday and repent for his sin. He didn't care if they couldn't forgive him. To him, it was more important to help them live a comfortable life after all the things they had done for him. And he was going to try his best to make that happen.

I wish to never relive that tragedy ever again.

Just then, his life in South Korea came to mind. There was something he direly wanted to erase but couldn't, a memory so painful that it was unforgettable. The day he had to bid farewell to his parents, who chose to end their own lives.

I don't want to experience that here.

At that time, in South Korea, he had been too naive and ignorant of the world and had nothing. He had failed to protect them. But now, he was different.

I can do it.

Lloyd was certain that he could protect them. He wanted to protect them. He never wanted to feel the same sorrow and regret he felt on that particular day ever again.

“I will do my best.”

Lloyd then grinned at them as if everything was all right, and his grin reflected his determination.

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Chapter 254: The Restoration Force of Destiny (2)

Swoosh! Splash! Below the spring sun, cargo ships arrived as they cut through the splashing waves, and people busily moved on and off the ships. After all this time, Port Cremo was still a bustling scene. It was also more vibrant than the last time Lloyd had come here. He felt a sense of inexplicable emotion at the sight.

“Whew.”

The vibrant scene of the port was all possible due to his success in getting rid of the Gigatitan. As the giant monster vanished, the looming threat over the port had forever disappeared, inviting in ships from all across the world and making the port as energetic as it was in the present moment. Lloyd tightened his fists as he had this thought. Did he do so because he felt a sense of accomplishment? No.

Ugh...! I should have asked for more pay!

He belatedly regretted his decision then. He felt a wave of resentment as bitter as a strong cup of espresso when he recalled his work here a few years ago.

It was a given that the port would be developed once I captured the Gigatitan... But I didn’t know it would be to this extent. I was foolish. Idiotic. Too relaxed. I should have been more forward and asked for a bigger compensation. Or I should have at least insisted on receiving a small portion of the customs tax for this port.

Had he acted thick-skinned and shamelessly asked for more, he would have been rolling in money earlier. What would have happened if he received one percent of the customs tax when the amount of trade occurring grew exponentially? He wouldn’t have had to whine to the queen to fund his fiefdom or worked so hard to make money in Namaran.

My life could have been so much easier! Ugh!

Lloyd wiped the tears that welled up in his eyes like humidity in a basement studio during the rainy season. The scenery of Port Cremo in all of its bustle and hustle under the bright sun. This beautiful sight made him green with envy. Naturally, his steps became more hurried.

“Tsk... Let’s get right into business,” blurted Lloyd.

“Do you plan on requesting an audience with Count Cremo?”

“Yeah, of course,” replied Lloyd after turning around and grinning at Javier following behind him. “Isn’t it a given to first greet the most powerful individual in a particular place wherever you go?”

“Truly, that sounds like the course of action for a sycophant who leeches off those in power,” retorted Javier.

“Ehem. Can’t you call it a daily course of action for ordinary people instead?” suggested Lloyd.

“Well, I have never lived like that before.”

“Wow. That must be nice. I’m jealous,” replied Lloyd sardonically.

“Yes, it is. All of this is thanks to the kindness of the lord. He allowed me to only focus on swordsmanship growing up.”

But what about you? What kind of life did you live in your world? Javier gazed at Lloyd in a meaningful way, and he recalled the things he accidentally heard many mornings before they left the fiefdom. He didn’t mean to listen, but it just happened.

Dragon King Verkis. Master Lloyd said something strange after he woke him up every morning.

At first, when he heard about the possibility of the altered state of destiny returning back to its original course, how this world was a fictional world, and how the people he had saved, including the count and countess and Julian, would pass away after a series of accidents, Javier thought it was all

a lie. He believed that Lloyd was saying those strange things to pester Verkis. But he started to think differently as he listened to him every day.

His story was too consistent to be dismissed as gibberish.

Moreover, this Lloyd wasn't real. This man was Suho Kim from another world. And when Javier remembered that, the things he first considered silly started to sound different, particularly about the calamities that would fall on Count and Countess Frontera. It was shocking. It was his first time learning that this world was a fictional story in another dimension. Moreover, in that story, the Frontera barony devastatingly crumbled, and fake Lloyd had been the one to prevent this tragedy from happening.

But then Master Lloyd said that a similar tragedy will strike again. And he has to put a stop to it... That was why he begged the dragon king for a solution.

Javier cast a meaningful gaze toward Lloyd, who was walking ahead of him.

Maybe my choice was not wrong then.

Javier had decided to watch over him even after he learned that the man in front of him was a fraud. There was a time when he agonized about his judgments in this matter. But now, his decision and resolution to observe and protect fake Lloyd appeared to have been the right choice.

That is why I did it. It's why I followed you to Cremo without any fight. It's why I decided to protect you.

If the tragedy in the Frontera family can be stopped, Javier was ready to protect and obey the fake Lloyd and risk all dangers. Just like he has always done up to this point. Much like the thinking when he left the Frontera fiefdom two days ago. Much like the resolution he chewed over throughout the travel by Ggoming. And before he knew it, he was already at the manor of Count Cremo.

"Woah. It's been a while."

Lloyd looked up at the manor with a different emotion than his last memories here. Back then, when he first set foot here, he was struggling as he had yet to pay off his family's debt.

Though it's not like my family is too great now, either.

No, in some sense, he was faced with a greater threat than a mountain of debt. At this rate, three years later, starting with Count Frontera, everyone around him was expected to meet a tragic death one by one. It was imperative for him to find a clue for a solution to stop these incidents from occurring. Resolved, he entered the manor and told the guard who he was and his purpose for a visit. Thankfully, he didn't need to wait long afterward as Count Cremo rushed to leave everything behind and escort Lloyd before anything else.

"My, my, how long has it been!" exclaimed Count Cremo in sheer joy. "The hero of Cremo! The pride of the Cremona region. For what reason have you traveled all the way here for, Lloyd Frontera?"

"Ahaha..."

"Hmm? Why are you chuckling like so?"

"Nothing. It's just that you seemed to have become much more lively than when I last saw you a while ago."

"This is all thanks to you." Count Cremo smiled brightly. "As soon as the Gigatitan was gone, trading ships came to my port in batches! And look who is living the life! Hahaha!"

Thwack! Thwack! Count Cremo tapped Lloyd's back with his steel-like or bear-like hand.

His treating me entirely differently from before.

Lloyd suppressed his smile. On his first visit here, he had to come up with all sorts of gimmicks to win the construction contract. But now, it was

different. The success he had with catching the Gigatitan alone elevated his status as the hero of Cremo.

But first, let's focus on the main reason I came here.

Lloyd focused his mind. He wasn't here to be served as an honored guest and show off. As soon as they sat down at a table, Lloyd shared the purpose of his visit to Count Cremo, who was sitting across from him.

"Um, I came here to ask you a favor, Your Excellency."

"Favor? What is it?" replied Count Cremo, intrigued.

"Could you find the most capable whaler in this port for me?" asked Lloyd.

"A whaler? Do you mean those at the whaling ship hunting the emperor whales?"

"Yes, that is what I mean," affirmed Lloyd with a nod. Experienced whalers who sailed in the Arctic Ocean. Only they would be able to give him a clue about the Mermaid Kingdom. Those were the expectations Lloyd held, and he wasn't disappointed.

"I know a few whalers. And some must be lodging at the port just in time. Do you have business with them?" asked Count Cremo.

"Yes, I do, and I would like to meet at their earliest convenience. I have some questions."

"I see. Then I shall set up the meeting. But..." Count Cremo stopped after nodding pleasantly. And he threw a meaningful gaze at Lloyd and said, "My dear hero of Cremo. The pride of the Cremona region. Could you remind me of your age?"

"Excuse me...? My age?" asked Lloyd, dazed.

"You seem to be well past the age to start a family. Tell me, are you not in a hurry?"

“No, I am not,” said Lloyd flatly.

“Really?”

“Yes, truly.”

“Not at all?” insisted Count Cremo once again.

“No. Not at all.”

“Tsk. You do not have to be so adamant.”

“Please forgive me.” Lloyd smiled humbly, realizing that Count Cremo still hadn’t given up on Lloyd. He figured that was the case with many nobles in the kingdom. But he had no plans on accepting their marriage offers.

I’m sorry. I just want to date normally and get married just like everyone else.

Lloyd despised the thought of marrying someone he never met and didn’t love just for the sake of business. And so, he wanted to marry someone from a humble background instead of a noble lady.

Anyway, that’s not important right now.

Having succeeded in evading the pressure from the count, Lloyd left the manor right away. The following day, the message from Count Cremo came that the meeting with the seasoned whaler was set up.

“Allow me to introduce you to him,” motioned Count Cremo. “This is Felipe. He is the most experienced seaman I know and has been the captain of the fastest whaling ship in the Arctic Ocean, Feliconia, for the past 23 years.”

“Nice to meet you. I am Felipe.” As soon as Count Cremo finished his introduction, Captain Felipe offered a handshake to Lloyd.

“Nice to meet you. My name is Lloyd Frontera.”

Lloyd felt that this man's hands were thick, full of callous and rough edges. With one manly handshake, Lloyd instantly knew how many storms Captain Felipe had overcome all these years.

Count Cremo brought an extremely experienced sailor.

Captain Felipe must have squinted a lot to gaze beyond the horizon, Lloyd thought, because tiny wrinkles naturally sat around his eyes. But even his eyes seemed to reveal his abundant experience.

Feeling that this man could be trusted, Lloyd brought out the topic at hand. "Thank you, Your Excellency, for making this meeting possible. I was in need of someone like you, Captain Felipe, as I had a question to ask."

"To me?" Felipe replied. "What could you be so curious about?"

"Tell me, are you well aware of the mermaids?" asked Lloyd.

"Mermaids?"

"Yes," replied Lloyd with a nod. "Certainly, I myself know as much as everybody does. Mermaids are the strongest creatures in the sea. They whiz and swim around the seas with their massive strength and swimming capability, and even the Gigatitan are terrified of their corps."

"Hmm," mused Felipe, "I can tell you know as much as what is possible for a regular person. What more do you want to know?"

"I wish to know the location of the Mermaid Kingdom."

"The Mermaid Kingdom?"

"Yes."

"Why do you want to know?"

"For personal reasons."

“So, you have a business that requires you to go find the Mermaid Kingdom?”

“Yes, do you know where it is?”

“No, I don’t. But I somewhat know a way to find it,” replied Felipe, his eye wrinkles deepening.

Lloyd’s eyes glimmered. “Can you tell me more?”

“Well, that isn’t too difficult,” said Felipe. “Go to the Arctic Ocean. The sea with the coldest winds and waves whose giant floating icebergs intimidate all nearby ships. The deepest area under these waters is where you can find their kingdom.”

“Yikes.” Lloyd found himself clenching his fists. It was done. At last, he came to know it. It should be accurate, given that it’s coming from the old hand in sailing. And so, the only thing left for Lloyd was to call Draggy and get ready to take a dive into the Arctic Ocean. Just then, Felipe spoke and shattered Lloyd’s plan altogether.

“But even if you know the location, you can’t go there.”

“Pardon? What are you talking about?” replied Lloyd, bemused.

“It’s just as I said. Even if you know the location, you can’t just go there.”

“Is it because it’s too deep?”

If the kingdom sat in the deepest part of the sea, that would be slightly problematic. Draggy should be okay, but Lloyd wouldn’t be able to withstand the water pressure. In any case, the Asrahan Core Technique and manaheart had their limitations.

Um, does that mean I should pay a huge sum to get some magic done on me?

Lloyd’s thought was soon interrupted by Felipe, who chuckled and shook his head slowly.

“Too deep, you say... No, the problem is not that simple. This is a matter of gaining permission.”

“Permission?”

“That’s what I heard. That is, from the old-timers when I was still just a newbie. They told me that if I ever bump into a mermaid in the sea, I must ask permission to pass through the sea since the sea is their home. The same goes when you have any business to visit their kingdom, I’ve been told.”

The captain paused for a while until he began again soon.

“Of course, what I’m telling you right now may sound strange. But I can tell you with certainty that you need their permission and recognition before you can go to their kingdom.”

“Um, excuse me, but do you have proof to back you up?” asked Lloyd politely.

“Of course I do. I’ve been there.”

“Wait, to the Mermaid Kingdom?” Lloyd’s voice cracked in surprise.

“Yes. Just once. It was for just a brief moment. It was before I even turned 20, so about 31 years ago. I was cracking and removing the ice stuck in the sides of the ship that day. Then I slipped and fell into the sea. I could feel the freezing cold in an instant.”

“So, what happened?”

“I screamed. But the wind and snowstorm were too strong, so nobody on the ship heard me. Eventually, the ship sailed on without me, and I thought I’d freeze to death. I was scared and despaired. That was the moment when a creature I’ve never seen before appeared in front of me.”

“A mermaid.”

“Yes. They were big. And they stared right at me. They seemed confused about whether I was an intruder or not. Scared, I frantically thought that I

must show that I was no intruder. So, I acted out until I succeeded, and under their permission, I was allowed a short visit down to the kingdom with them, where I received treatment and safely made it back to the land."

"Wow. Are you serious?"

"How else am I alive now and be with you now?" chuckled Captain Felipe.

"Wow."

Lloyd was amazed. Truly, this man was a veteran in sailing who experienced all sorts of storms.

I've done it.

Lloyd clenched his fists. The Jewel of Truth that had been mentioned by Dragon King Verkis. It was a legendary artifact among mermaids that could stop the restoration of destiny. At least, it would be able to stop those awful incidents from happening. And that was why he traveled all the way to be here, that is, to find out more about the Mermaid Kingdom.

Awesome.

Lloyd was able to locate a person who had been to the Mermaid Kingdom with one quick search. He felt like he made acquaintance with a tour guide of the Mermaid Kingdom instead of merely obtaining a clue about the place.

"Then..." Lloyd spoke, his voice growing with expectation. "When you met the mermaid in the sea, what did you do to get its recognition?"

"Do you mean the secret behind earning their acceptance?"

"Yes."

Lloyd nodded. At last, he would finally hear the answer he had been searching for. He could go to the Mermaid Kingdom! At that very moment, a strong, fiery ember of hope ignited in his heart. Captain Felipe grinned and gave an answer.

“I sang the mermaid a beautiful melody.”

What the hell did you just say?

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Chapter 255: Singing with a Genuine Heart (1)

What the hell did you just say?

Lloyd hardly swore. This was true no matter what horrible or sickening situation he was in. It was simply something he didn't like to do. He grumbled to himself instead of cursing. But the moment just now was an exception. As soon as he heard Captain Felpie's serious and gentle words, Lloyd was almost triggered to grab him by the collar and shake him several times. The reason wasn't hard to understand.

Singing? Did you say singing? A beautiful singing voice?!

If there was one skill that he sucked at, it was singing. Lloyd was very good at evaluating himself, so he had a keen perception of his limitations. Singing was a notable weakness of his. He had no expectations for himself to be able to sing a beautiful melody. To him, it was more realistic for a newly-enrolled engineering student to make a semiconductor than for him to sing well.

But what? Sing?

Laughter spilled out of him. He was too dumbfounded. But he couldn't give up like this. The

restoration of destiny needed to be stopped, and that required obtaining the legendary jewel rumored to be in the Mermaid Kingdom.

"But, um, must I really have to sing?"

"Hmm?" Captain Felipe cocked his head to the side.

Lloyd stared at him in desperation as if he was grabbing a branch in the river amid the sweeping current or searching for some lifting insoles before going out on a surprise blind date. Banking on his hope, he asked, "Isn't it? Do I have to sing? I should only prove that I'm not an enemy or an intruder. For example, through dancing or whispering."

“Hmm, I don’t know. I have never tried any other method. I was drowning in water at the time and didn’t have time to think. Also, dancing and whispering? Why would you have to resort to such methods? You already have the most foolproof method that has been verified by me, singing.” Captain Felipe shrugged.

“...”

Thinking to himself that this aforementioned verified method wasn’t going to be possible, Lloyd wanted to cry. But he couldn’t abandon hope just yet. So he asked, “Um, then, will any song do?”

“Any song?” There was curiosity and dismay in Captain Felipe’s voice. “What do you mean by that?”

“So, um, I am asking if it’s okay if this friend over here sings instead of me.”

Lloyd pointed to Javier beside him. Captain Felipe’s gaze flickered over to Javier and came back to Lloyd. He shook his head. “I don’t think so.”

“Why not?” whined Lloyd.

“I heard it directly from the mermaid that saved me.”

“What did they say?”

“That it responds to the song personally sung by the one in dire need. So a song sung by someone other than the one who has business with the kingdom will not convince the mermaids,” said Felipe firmly.

“Then, I have to be the one to sing no matter what?”

“That appears to be the case.”

“...”

“What’s wrong? Is there a problem?” asked Captain Felipe.

“...”

Yes, there are a lot of problems. Lloyd smiled as he stared at the captain. It was the smile of someone who has given up on everything.

“I am quite cautious about telling you this,” interrupted Javier on Lloyd’s behalf, “But Master Lloyd cannot sing.”

“He cannot sing?” asked Captain Felipe.

“Yes,” affirmed Javier.

“How bad is it?”

“Have you heard of the rumor back in Namaran, the city of trade?”

“Oh, yes, I have. How the Hell’s Knight made a fuss there.”

“Yes,” acknowledged Javier, “And Hell’s Knight writhed in pain after hearing him sing.”

“Writhed in pain, you say? Why?” Genuine curiosity flashed across Felipe’s face.

“...”

“It cannot be!” A look of shock came on the captain’s face when he realized the meaning of silence.

“Your guess is right,” affirmed Javier.

“Ehem... Hmm!” Captain Felipe cleared his throat. “His singing is so horrible that it can even torment the Hell’s Knight from the underworld?”

“Simply put, the noise of nails scratching on a chalkboard would be more melodious. Otherwise, a parasite living inside your intestine will be better at singing than Master Lloyd.”

“Whew, I see now.”

Stop it, you dimwits... I’m right here. Haah.

Lloyd heaved a long sigh, wiping off the drops of tears starting to form in his eyes. Just then, the captain tapped his shoulder twice and spoke with the most generous and easygoing expression on his face in the world.

“It’s okay. Singing, well… It doesn’t matter if you’re not good at it.”

“Excuse me?”

“It looks like you’ve misunderstood me.” Captain Felipe went on, “When I spoke of melodious singing, I wasn’t referring to a singer with great technique or voice.”

“Then what did you mean?” Lloyd looked at Captain Felipe for understanding.

“Sincerity and genuineness.” The captain’s gaze turned serious. “In fact, I didn’t sing well when I was in the water as well. How could I? Think about it. I was plunged into the icy water, and my voice was rough and coarse after having screamed too many times for the distancing ship to come back. What do you think my singing would’ve sounded like?”

“Um, not very good,” supposed Lloyd.

“You’re right. It was the worst.” Captain Felipe chuckled. “My awful singing wasn’t something a sound mind could bear. The tone was off, and my voice was shaky and off-key. I didn’t expect the mermaid in front of me to like my singing, which was done in a dire state of desperation as there was nothing else I could do.”

“Then I suppose the mermaid thought kindly of your singing nonetheless.”

“Yes,” replied the captain, whose smile deepened. “At first, it cocked its head and stared right at my eyes. That was when I felt it. It was paying attention to my singing, realizing from my desperate cry that I’m no enemy or an intruder.”

“Your sincerity and genuineness were conveyed to the mermaid.”

“That’s exactly it,” replied the captain, tightening his grip on Lloyd’s shoulder. “So, you don’t have to be discouraged just because you can’t sing. That only tells me about your vocal technique. What you need to do here is sing genuinely and sincerely.”

“You are saying that my singing can work well enough.”

“Speaking from experience, yes.”

“Thank you.”

At last, Lloyd was able to smile, and his heart felt lighter. It turned out the captain, who was speaking from experience, was right.

Right. I jumped to the conclusion too fast. It’s a mermaid, not a human. It wouldn’t be strange for them to have different singing criteria than humans. There’s no need to worry right now. I just need to show them my sincerity.

Now, he was confident. This was the first time he ever had that sort of emotion toward his singing. That probably was the reason why he managed to ask the captain the following.

“Um, excuse me, captain,” called Lloyd after seeing Captain Felipe was about to leave.

“Yes? Do you have anything else you would like to ask?”

“Yes. What is your recent schedule for a voyage?”

“My sailing schedule, you mean?”

“Yes. Since we’re talking about this matter anyway, I’d like to make contact with the mermaids in the Arctic Ocean, but if possible, I’d like to receive help from a seasoned sailor like you.”

Lloyd revealed his plan in earnest. He had to go look for the Mermaid Kingdom no matter what, and that required him to go to the Arctic Ocean. If this was the case, he reasoned that it was better to travel via ship cruised by an experienced captain.

I could fly with Ggoming or Draggy for comfort. But I don't think that's what I should do this time.

Ggoming was a parrotbill, so he wasn't suitable for a long-hour flight. Even more, he needed to rest several times a day when things got too tiring for him. But taking a break was impossible in the northern sea.

It's too cold and also vast with no land in sight. There are glaciers, but I don't think that would let us take a proper break.

At the same time, flying with Draggy didn't sound that comfortable.

Sure, it won't get exhausted like Ggoming. But it's too big and intimidating. The mere presence of Draggy alone will be a great threat to the mermaids.

It would wreck the mood around them and ruin everything. What Lloyd needed was to engage with the mermaids with an earnest heart, and taking Draggy would only give the impression that Lloyd was an intruder from the very beginning. Lloyd didn't want that to happen.

"And you will receive a generous payment from me. Could you travel with us?" suggested Lloyd.

"Hmm, does that mean you will pay to reserve the entire ship?"

"Indeed."

"Not to mention, the journey is to the Arctic Ocean. Tsk. Are you asking me this even when you know that it's off-season for hunting emperor whales?"

"And that is exactly why I am pleading even harder."

"Hmm." Captain Felipe pondered. "I shall have to bring back my crew on break at the moment, and the payment should be at least doubled, given there will be more icebergs than usual to make the trip that much more dangerous."

"It is all right," said Lloyd, "I have a lot of money."

“Really?”

“Yes,” said Lloyd as he brought out a bag and put it on the table. The bag made a thick, thudding noise, and the table creaked. Captain’s eyes shook slightly.

“...”

“You can look at what’s inside,” added Lloyd.

“Ehem...!”

Captain glanced and there, inside the bag, were dazzling pieces of jewelry and treasure Lloyd had taken from the dragon cave. The wrinkles around the captain’s eyes, the mark of his turbulent years, wiggled.

“If you’re saying this a retainer, then the total payment will be-”

“Five times more than what’s in the bag,” said Lloyd.

“So are we leaving today?” Captain Felipe didn’t hesitate anymore.

“Thank you, captain.”

And surely, money talked. Everything from that point on proceeded very smoothly, the preparation for the journey was done at lightning speed. The captain had summoned all the crew members on vacation to his ship within one day, and though they grumbled at first, they all hurriedly scrambled to get on board when the captain offered them an exorbitant amount of money.

Similarly, he was easily able to prepare the food and water for the trip, thanks to the help of Count Cremo, who still wanted Lloyd to be his son-in-law. He generously provided everything needed for the expedition as if he was trying to put Lloyd in his debt.

And just like that, Feliconia managed to depart Cremo before sunset and set out on the restless journey toward the Arctic Ocean. The weather was clear, and the wind was gentle. The waves were calm, and the current was stable.

This is a relief. I was worried that I'd get seasick.

A sense of relief rushed through Lloyd. To be honest, he had been on a ship just once when he rode a cruise ship in the Han River during his childhood. So he was slightly worried.

It's been the first time since I've been on the whaling ship. I was so worried that I'd vomit everything I'd eaten.

But thankfully, it didn't happen. The sail was smooth. And finally, on the 20th day of the expedition, Captain Felipe told Lloyd, "We have arrived at the destination."

"This is the place?" asked Lloyd.

"Yes. We're in the Arctic Ocean. Though technically speaking, we are just at the entrance."

Lloyd looked around. The deck was spotlessly clean, and over the ship rails and in between the thick cold air that formed each time he breathed, the dark sea spanned without end. Glaciers floated around here and there, and the whole scenery was typical of the Arctic Ocean documentaries Lloyd had seen on TV.

The captain continued, "So I think you should sing here."

"Really? Sing here?" asked Lloyd, uncertain.

"Yes. I don't know if you can feel it, but there are already mermaids around us. They have been increasing in number after starting to follow us yesterday." The captain glanced at the sea.

"Don't ask me how I know. I can only guess from observing the movement of the birds and sardines. Anyway, a fair number of mermaids are surrounding our ship now. So it's time that we let them know we're not intruders."

"You speak as though we might get attacked otherwise," said Lloyd.

“Precisely.” The captain smiled bitterly. “They are very closed off. It has been decades since they last took me in, and that was only for a short while. And so, it’s time that you appease them with your singing. Otherwise, we’ll be marked as intruders and either get attacked or banished from the ocean.”

“Whew... All right.”

Lloyd glanced at Javier briefly as he listened to the captain. Javier affirmed the latter by slightly giving a nod. The mermaids were indeed enveloping the ship, which he knew based on his acute senses as a grandmaster. So Lloyd knew it was time for him to act.

“Ehem... Hmm!”

Lloyd let out a few dry coughs as he calmed down, and he took a step forward toward the edge of the ship, his heart thumping. The sharp mast stood tall. Lloyd stood on the bow spirit, which was the most conspicuous area for the mermaids down the sea. It was a conducive place to express his genuineness and sincerity through his singing.

Whew.

Lloyd took a deep breath, calming his heart. And he reflected on his honest feelings then.

I want to save everyone. The count. The countess. Julian. Sheherazade. I’d hate to see the queen with a paralyzed arm. And to that end... I have to convey my sincerity to the mermaids here.

Lloyd gazed down at the dark sea. The mermaids must be observing him from there. Lloyd wished his sincerity would be felt so they would no longer be hostile. Lloyd dared to wish so.

Carefully and genuinely, in a trembling voice, he sang. While still lacking technique and in an unstable tone, he instilled sincerity from the bottom of his heart. He hoped and yearned that his honesty would lower their guard and hostility.

Sometime later, the mermaids laid a merciless salvo of attack against the Feliconia Ship.

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Chapter 256: Singing with a Genuine Heart (2)

Splash! Ice-filled waves crashed down with a gruesome noise and hit the flank of Feliconia, the gigantic whaling ship. The ship, which had overcome countless tribulations and raging storms, staggered. Icy water flooded over the upper part of its poop deck, soaking Captain Felipe in the process.

“Hard over! Port!” yelled Captain Felipe.

“Hard over!” repeated the boatswain, relaying the captain’s instruction to the rowing room beneath the deck. The rowing sailors’ back muscles moved in response like waves of water. As the experienced captain smoothly turned the wheel, the huge ship swerved to the port, and the rowing room yelled in accordance with the changing angle.

“Port! Let fall! Four! Starboard! Give way together! One!”

“Whew! Ha!”

The rowing sailors synchronized their breaths, but the rhythm of their rows started to shift. The portside sailors stroked once every four breaths, while the starboard sailors did so with every breath they took. The different movements of the oars immediately led to a change in the ship's movement. *Splaaash!*

The front of the ship drastically swerved to the left like a stirring eel, its giant body whipping left and cutting through the surrounding waves. Right after the ship took a sudden left turn, a series of muscular individuals jumped out of the water like dolphins. But they weren’t dolphins. *Splash! Plash! Splash!*

“Acck!”

“We missed it!”

Their muscular torsos glimmered in the seawater, and below that, they had a fin with scales that brilliantly reflected against the light. They were

mermaids. During the split second they jumped above the water, some stared at the Feliconia, shuddering in anger that their majestic attack had failed. But they didn't give up easily. This only marked the beginning of their attack.

"Sisters! Do not lose the intruder!"

"We protect our sea with our own hands!"

"Break the keel in one go!"

Over 500 mermaids charged at the ship as they swayed their fins at full speed from the deepest part of the sea. And they charged forward with sheer strength and tried to ram their bodies into the lower part of the ship.

Crash! Boom! Thump! Although the ship was performing well in its maneuvering, it failed to dodge the violent ambush from the hoard of mermaids. The hull heaved at each of their attacks. An ominous thudding noise came from the ship. The look on Captain Felipe's face paled slightly. But Lloyd's face looked more urgent than that of the captain.

"Wait, captain?!" bawled Lloyd, who was terrified by the sudden shift of the atmosphere right after the mermaids carried out their violent ambush. He almost fell off the bowsprit and dove into the sea.

"Singing! I thought that was enough! I thought being sincere and genuine was enough!" Lloyd screamed at the captain, his voice dripping with sheer bitterness. He had come down and crawled through the deck, which was rocking from the ship's drastic maneuvers and mermaids' attacks.

You said it'd work! You said I only have to sing sincerely with all my heart!

So he did. And with all of his heart. There was seriousness, warmth, and desperation in his singing. He wanted to save the count and countess, Julian, and so many others. He had sung, direly asking for the mermaids to offer him a little help and signaling that he was no enemy or intruder.

“Then why?! Why is this happening?!” ranted Lloyd, still feeling embittered.

Captain Felipe wheeled around at that. “Hey! I told you to sing!” He shot a dumbstruck glance as he busily steered the wheel. “My gracious! Why is this happening, you ask? Can’t you tell? I told you to sing! With all of your heart!”

“Yes, you did!” shouted Lloyd. “That’s why I sang!”

“That... was what you call singing?” Captain Felipe froze and cocked his head to the side as though he was saying, “Are you for real?” And then he started, which was dead serious and grim that Lloyd almost broke down and burst into tears. Unperturbed, the captain went on, “Come on! You should have just sung a normal song instead of making my ears bleed with that awful sound! Why did you even bother with such a poor attempt? Tsk!”

Lloyd was speechless.

“It’s not too late now. How about giving it a proper try this time?” suggested the captain.

Still, Lloyd said nothing.

“Hey! What are you doing?! Stop crying and say something!”

“...”

Lloyd wanted to burst into tears and ask what the captain would do in his place. He was getting beaten to the bone from the verbal attacks coming at him with every passing second. Lloyd forced himself to hold back his tears and changed the subject.

“Tsk! I won’t sing! Let’s just get out of here since it looks like I’ll need to use another method.”

That seemed to be the best option. The singing approach the captain suggested seemed to be a failure since it made them look like a threat

instead of opening the mermaids' hearts. So, right now, the best they could do was run away.

Then I'll have to look for another method. Really, if I really have no other choices, I'll bring Draggy and invade the kingdom.

If no method worked. If he couldn't be friends with the mermaids, it seemed he would have to consider using brute force.

But that's my last resort. Right now, escaping this place safely comes first.

Lloyd anxiously observed the situation. It wasn't looking good.

Clang! Crash! Boom! Noises crept up from the bottom of the ship nonstop. It looked like the mermaids were trying to bore a hole in the bottom of the ship by ramming against it, and each attempt created a fierce vibration on impact.

I've got a bad feeling about this.

Lloyd's face slightly darkened. Truly, the situation was bad, and it was going to get worse.

Even though this ship is huge, it won't be able to hold on forever.

The whaling ship was manufactured for the sole purpose of hunting emperor whales. This meant that the ship carried a fair number of oars and a sail that ensured a safe escape from a pod of whales even while transporting hundreds of tons of whale carcasses. The design also gave the ship explosive maneuvering capabilities despite its huge size. Furthermore, since the ship had to endure the frantic effort of whales to break free from a harpoon, it was designed to be incomparably more durable than an ordinary ship.

But we are up against a terrible opponent.

They were up against mermaids. The most powerful creatures in the sea. The aqua tyrant that made even emperor whales tremble in fear. That was what mermaids were.

It is said they're exceptionally strong. Their strength is rumored to equal the strongest of the orc warriors. Moreover, there are hundreds of these creatures coming at us at once... If we allow their attacks to continue, the bottom of the ship will eventually break.

Of course, the ship would last for a while even if there was a hole on the bottom of it. The vehicle was designed to withstand the attacks of emperor whales. It wouldn't sink from a few holes and a bit of flooding.

But what if we get unlucky and the keel snaps?

The keel was the spine of the ship. If it broke, it was over for them. The partition structure of the vehicle that prevented flooding would be useless the moment its keel broke. The real problem was that the mermaids were strong enough to break the keel.

Right now, the ship has just barely been able to avoid any direct attacks on its keel with some impressive maneuvers, but there's no guarantee that this luck will continue.

Lloyd objectively observed the situation. It was bad.

And it's not like we can fight back.

Technically, he could. He could order Bangul to use his volcanic discharge or have Hamang create a whirlpool by absorbing water and spitting it back. Or he and Javier could set off their mana blast into the sea.

But that's too dangerous.

Lloyd shook his head. It was dangerous not to them but to the mermaids.

I need their help. What if I fight back and hurt the mermaids? Then that'd be the end. It'd be a complete deal breaker.

From then on, he'd be their archenemy. Any chance of convincing or persuading them would disappear, much like a cup of instant ramen that had been spilled on the ground.

Then there's only one way left for us.

At last, Lloyd made a decision. He shouted at the captain, "Captain! How long do you think we can continue on like this?"

"Continue on? What do you mean?" replied Captain Felipe aloud.

"I mean, stay in one piece without sinking!"

"If we're lucky, all day!"

"And if we're unlucky?"

"One second!"

"..."

So, in short, the whole thing rested on luck. Gripping himself together, Lloyd said, "Then I'll try to strike a negotiation with them."

"Negotiate? In our current situation?" Captain Felipe asked.

"Yes," replied Lloyd. "Though I don't expect it to work!"

"Are you trying to buy us time?"

"They might employ less attacks on us while they listen to me speak! So, do you understand what to do when I start negotiating with them?"

"I see. Escape instead of evading."

It was vital for them to get out of this sea. Once that happened, there would be fewer glaciers around them, and the ship would be able to move freely without the fear of crashing into one. They would have an increased chance of escaping without harm. Like the experienced sailor he was, Captain Felipe understood Lloyd's intention in a flash and nodded. A satisfied smile appeared on Lloyd's face.

Okay. Let's give it a try.

Lloyd loosened the muscles around his mouth and went down to the ship's poop. And he stuck his body out of the edge, the icy waves breaking in real-time, and he gave a mana-loaded shout down below.

"There! Mermaid sisters! I actually have a question!"

His shouting made its way into the waves, reaching the ears of the mermaids throwing their bodies at the ship.

Lloyd shouted once more, "I know that I upset you all with my strange and terrifying singing, but you see! I'm curious! What can I do to appease your anger?!"

Your anger! Your anger! Your anger...

His yelling spread more ferociously, further and deeper into the sea, at last bringing the mermaids to stop their attacks for a second. Everyone's gaze moved beyond the sea and fixed on Lloyd, whose body was protruding out of the ship. They became livid.

"That's him!" one of the mermaids shouted. "Yes! That's the guy who sang!"

"That wasn't singing! It was a curse that used sound waves!"

"My ears are still bleeding from the noise!"

Every single mermaid's eyes burned with rage, and they soon became hellbent on catching and ending the human in their view. They would sew his mouth shut to make sure that he wouldn't defile the sea with his disgusting singing and screeching ever again. The Mermaid Corps resumed attacking after cementing their spirits with burning anger and determination. *Swoosh!*

"Eek...?"

Just then, Lloyd spotted one mermaid barreling up below the sea and winding up to punch him. Lloyd fell back in surprise, but it was too late.

Shoot! The fist was coming too quickly at him, and Lloyd saw the massive forearm and shoulder muscles attached behind it. And he also saw the burning eyes of his attacker. It was evidently the eyes of a warrior.

She's going to kill me!

But he couldn't do anything. The fist was flying toward him with unexpectedly great speed and power, and his reaction to it was pathetically slow in comparison. The moment he had this realization, he became certain.

I'm going to get punched.

What would happen if she hit me? Lloyd wondered. He would get a fractured jaw at the very least.

If I'm unlucky, I might have to eat nothing but porridge for the rest of my life.

He didn't want that to happen, but there was nothing he could do. At that moment, all he could do was extract mana from his manaheart and amp up his mana with the Asrahan Core Technique. And as a result, avoid shattering his jaw by slightly raising his defensive capabilities.

Ugh. Please!

Lloyd clamped his eyes shut, hoping that it wouldn't be too painful. Just then...

Baaam! He registered a loud banging noise coming right below his jaw. He opened his eyes in fright. Then he saw.

Javier?

Javier, whom Lloyd didn't notice coming, had his hand outstretched, blocking the punch with his palm.

"Hmph!"

The mermaid became wide-eyed when her punch was blocked. In response, she instantly twirled her body to wield her muscular tail, which was thicker than a log of wood. It swung with a sharp noise, and Lloyd feared that a mere brush would at least break every bone in his body. But it was nothing to Javier.

“It is dangerous. Please step back.”

Javier held out his hand and shoved Lloyd back before projecting his shoulder and bumping against the mermaid tail. The impact sent the mermaid flying back. *Whack!*

“Ack!”

The muscular mermaid sucked in a breath as she was sent off dozens of feet away. She crashed into the sea but swam down, unharmed from the blow. That was when Javier’s gaze went back to Lloyd.

“Are you all right, Master Lloyd?”

“Um... Yeah...”

Lloyd, who was thrown to the ground, nodded in a daze. He was unconsciously rubbing his jaw, and chills ran down his spine. In all seriousness, it was very dangerous a second ago. He might have gotten badly injured had Javier not intervened.

Dammit.

Lloyd shuddered when his attempt to buy time by negotiating failed.

I need to find a way out by any means possible.

Otherwise, this ship could really sink. He and Javier could escape with Ggoming, but Captain Felipe and his crew would be sacrificed.

I don’t want that.

He shook his head hard, racking his brain to find a solution. The situation continued to worsen nonetheless.

Crash! Clack! Creak! Crack!

As the mermaids flung their bodies at the ship and created a thumping noise, the ship began to gradually make a creaky noise that definitely signaled something worse.

“I fear that the ship is starting to topple by the impact,” said Javier, feeling nervous. Something terrible was about to happen.

I should save Master Lloyd first if the ship sinks.

Master Lloyd must be protected, come hell or high water. Even if he wasn’t the real one, now that he has become the pillar of the family, he was more important than the real one and required the utmost protection. At all costs. Regardless of any unreasonable situations, he shall be protected and guarded. Javier cemented his resolution when...

“Hmm. I’ve got no choice, given the situation. Javier. We need to fish for a bit,” announced Lloyd.

“Pardon? Fish?” Javier tilted his head at Lloyd’s words. Fish? Now? What could he mean? But there was no bait. How? And at last, Javier saw Lloyd hoisting a rope with a shameless smile on his face before the latter nonchalantly gave him an unbelievably absurd demand.

“You’ll have to be the bait. You won’t freeze to death in the water since you’re a grandmaster, right?”

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Chapter 257: The Affairs of the Mermaid Kingdom (1)

“You won’t freeze to death in the water since you’re a grandmaster, right?”

“...”

“Right?” said Lloyd.

“...”

What are you talking about, Master Lloyd? Javier shot an icy glower at Lloyd, understanding immediately what he was about to do.

“You can’t be thinking of using me as bait after suggesting for us to fish out of nowhere, could you, Master Lloyd?”

“Yeah. That’s correct.” Lloyd waggled his brows.

Javier didn’t respond.

“Um, are you happy that you got the answer in one try?”

“...”

I’m not happy. Rather, I wanted to trample you for just a second, Young Master. But Javier couldn’t express his sincere emotion because Lloyd hurriedly explained his plan.

“Hey, even though you may think I’m joking around here, you know this situation is serious, right?”

“I am aware of that.”

“That’s why.” Lloyd’s stare suddenly grew serious. “This won’t do. This ship won’t be able to endure if it continues to be attacked like now. Besides, those mermaids don’t look like they’ll give up any time soon.”

“I agree with you,” seconded Javier seriously.

“So, I need you to get in the water.”

“By being a bait, what plan do you exactly have on your mind?”

“A very scary bait.” Lloyd smiled scarily. “I never meant to fight back, but this won’t do. So, we just need to return one proper blow. One that won’t hurt them but send them the message to back off. You can do that, right?”

“Are you saying we can buy time to escape while they back off from the ship?”

“That’s right. How does it sound?”

“I think I can do that.” Javier nodded. He quickly understood Lloyd’s message. With one powerful and menacing counterattack, he would temporarily draw the mermaids back. In return, their frenzied attacks would be put to a halt and earn them some time.

“Great,” said Lloyd, “And this would be our best option if you can avoid getting hurt in the process.”

“I will try my best, Master Lloyd.”

A faint smile of satisfaction spread across Javier’s face. This was what he liked about fake Lloyd. Though there were times Lloyd acted like a nutcase, the man cared about his safety. However, realizing it wasn’t the time to think about this matter, Javier jumped into action.

“The rope. Please tie it to the mast.”

“Okay.”

Javier tightly tied the rope he received from Lloyd around his waist, and Lloyd tied its other end to the mast. Everything was set.

“Now, I will jump into the sea. The moment I lay a counterattack, please pull up the rope right away.”

“How will I know that you made a counterattack? Will you give me a separate signal?” asked Lloyd.

“No,” replied Javier, “You will know right away without one.”

“How?” Lloyd asked again.

Javier scoffed and then said, “Because I will overturn the sea.”

With that, Javier jumped up to the rail and threw a glance behind at Lloyd before diving in.

Splash! As soon as he plunged into the water, his body became wrapped in bitter cold, and Javier felt an icy sensation that seemed to be freezing his skin, muscles, and blood vessels. But Javier didn’t mind at all. He activated the Asrahan Core Technique to its full limit and reverberated all the manahearts that were woven into the cells of his body. He then ran a sweeping survey across the sea in a ferocious gaze, ready to roar, and noticed hundreds of mermaids rushing toward the ship. Javier was able to predict their incoming trajectory and movements before preparing to send a sweeping blow that would not hurt them but make them retreat.

I only have one chance.

Javier’s eyes shone much brighter than the cold blue sea. He gripped the hilt of his sword, harnessing his power. But soon, before he did anything, all the mermaids froze in place. Could it be that they sensed his dangerous energy with their almost wild instincts? The mermaids all ceased attacking the ship. Instead, with fright in their eyes and astonishment on their faces, they intensely stared at Javier. The latter lifted his brow at their abrupt change.

Did they figure out my plan?

It appeared so, indeed. But Javier didn’t care as he had already identified the location and line of trajectory for every single mermaid at sea. Now, he just had to sweep them hundreds of feet away by drawing his sword. But right when he was about to pull his sword out, one of the mermaids staring at Javier raised her hand. She then pointed at Javier’s face with a slight

blush and a trembling voice like a girl who had fallen in love for the first time, she murmured something along with everyone else.

“You pass.”

Swoosh. At once, the sea grew quiet. There weren’t any mermaids aggressively swimming around them anymore. The surrounding glaciers stopped clashing against each other. The only sound was from the quiet waves on the surface of the water. Javier flinched as the sea grew quiet. He grabbed the hilt of the sword he was about to pull. His eyes shone coldly.

“...”

Pass? What were they saying all of a sudden? What kind of trickery was this? Did they predict his counterattack already? Or were they buying time to ambush him later?

I cannot lower my guard.

Javier thought so. But at that moment, one of the mermaids that stopped attacking the ship swam over to Javier. Her manner was extremely careful compared to a while ago. When she was about 15 feet away from him, she asked, “Beautiful human. What is your name?”

“...”

Javier didn’t answer. He couldn’t actually because he wasn’t a mermaid. He didn’t have the ability to talk underwater. Realizing this, the mermaid nodded.

“Oops. I forgot. Humans don’t know how to talk underwater like us. I would like to have a conversation with you. Do you mind if we go above water for a while and talk?”

Javier simply stared without saying anything.

“It is all right. You passed. We won’t attack you.” The mermaid grinned as she opened her palms to Javier.

That wasn’t all. She even gave a strict order to the others.

“Everybody back off.”

With one command, the entire Mermaid Corps withdrew and loosened their siege. This sight relieved Javier a little, so he swam up to the surface without a word.

“Whew...”

Javier breathed out in between the splashing waves. A moment later, the mermaid surfaced as well, finally allowing Javier to take a proper look at the face of the individual who came forward as the representative of the mermaids.

“Nice to meet you. I am the commander of the third underwater guard team of the Mermaid Kingdom.”

“I am Javier Asrahan, a knight serving Count Frontera.”

“Javier Asrahan?”

“Yes,” affirmed Javier.

“Oh! Even your name is pretty.”

“...”

Javier frowned, his forehead wrinkling. The mermaid right in front of him and the others below were all acting the same way. They were blushing as they looked at him. Javier could easily presume why. He was used to this.

“Did you mean that my face has been approved?” asked Javier impassively.

“Oh! How did you know?” exclaimed the mermaid.

“I am familiar with this situation,” Javier nonchalantly spoke as if it was obvious. “I have been at the center of attention everywhere I went throughout my life for my looks, which have been received positively by

women. So I am not entirely unfamiliar with this situation. However...” Javier’s gaze slightly grew cold as he looked at the mermaid. “Despite my dashing face, you are the guard who protects this territory. From my understanding, we need your permission and approval to enter your kingdom.”

“Um, you are right,” seconded the mermaid nicely.

“I also heard that you must sing with great sincerity and care to gain approval. Am I correct?”

“Yes, that is roughly correct.”

“But I did not sing, you see,” Javier pointed out, fixing his gaze on her.

“It does not matter,” said the mermaid casually.

“It does not matter...? Wait-”

“Singing is not the only way to touch someone’s heart.”

Javier frowned, not understanding what she was saying.

Reading his face, she added, “What cares about singing when your face already has inspired us to give you our approval?” Her eyes glimmered very brightly as if what she said was obvious.

For some reason, Javier was overwhelmed by her eagerness.

“Then, do I really have permission to enter your kingdom? Just based on my appearance?” asked Javier.

“Of course. Didn’t you see how all my sisters gave their approval?”

“I see... Then could you give me a second?” asked Javier.

“Why? For what?”

“I would like to share the news with my company onboard.”

Javier fleetingly glanced toward the upper deck of the ship, and the mermaid commander shrugged. It was a silent agreement from her.

“I appreciate your kindness. Well then.”

Javier then jumped out of the water and got to the deck of the ship. Conveniently, the captain, crew, and Lloyd were gathered in the area to watch over the situation.

“What the? What happened? Why did they stop attacking when you didn’t even fight back?” asked Lloyd, who came to Javier before anyone else.

Shaking his hair dripping with seawater, Javier replied, “I believe I have attained their approval.”

“You what? You received their permission?” Lloyd frowned.

“Yes,” affirmed Javier.

“How?”

“They said my face had their approval.”

“...”

“Actually,” continued Javier, “When you think about it, it is nothing very surprising. I should have jumped into the water instead of having you sing, Master Lloyd, in the first place. Then the ship would not have been attacked like this.”

“...”

“Anyhow, what a relief it is that I have acquired approval from them in this way at least.”

“Yeah,” Lloyd huffed sarcastically, “It’s such a great relief that you’re handsome. Isn’t it? Hahahaha.”

“Yes. It is a big relief that I was able to prevent a destructive situation brought about by your hopeless singing with my handsome looks.”

“Yeah. What a relief, really. Oh, I’m so happy. Ahaha...”

“Master Lloyd.” Javier stared at Lloyd with a serious look.

“That’s right. What.”

“Please stop crying.”

“Shut up,” blurted Lloyd in denial. “My eyes are just dry from the salty sea breeze.”

“Anyway, you should first talk with the mermaid representative below,” suggested Javier with a smile.

“I was about to,” huffed Lloyd as he wiped his eyes with his sleeve and stuck his body out of the ship railing. When he looked down, he saw the mermaid in question.

Wow. Her muscles are unreal.

Amid the splashing waves, there was a fellow, no young lady, whose body was swaying in the water. Her muscles were nothing to joke about. They were bulky and brawn, and Lloyd realized again something he had felt when he built the mermaid statue in Port Cremo. The mermaid’s muscles appeared to be literal weapons that came from intensely training for 24 hours every day in the water their entire lives.

It’d be a sight to behold if I brought her to a gym alongside Orc Arosh.

The mermaid’s physique seemed to be on par with the orcs, whose bodies Lloyd had examined up close. But now wasn’t the time to admire her muscles. He cleared his throat.

“Hmm! Ehem! How are you? My name is Lloyd Frontera,” announced Lloyd aloud.

The mermaid commander simply stared back at Lloyd. Her eyes were marked with terrible boredom.

“I just heard from my personal knight, Sir Asrahan. I was told, ‘Thanks to your generosity, Sir Asrahan has gained your approval and praise for his beauty.’”

“Yes. And...?” the mermaid retorted.

“First, I would like to express my gratitude for your generous and wise decision.”

Lloyd smiled like a salesman. Could it be that worked? The same smile hung on the mermaid’s face.

“Gratitude?” she puffed. “We should be the grateful ones. We were able to enjoy a view of such an unimaginable beauty like him. It looks like today is our lucky day.”

“My,” replied Lloyd gleefully, “Thank you very much for saying so. Today appears to be a lucky day for us as well.”

“Lucky? What do you mean it is a lucky day for you?”

“Why else? I came to meet someone with such a generous and wise insight,” groveled Lloyd.

“Generous and wise insight, you say? But I just described what is beautiful to be beautiful. Nothing else.”

“Ahaha. Is that so? I see you are honest as well.”

“Who cares. Anyway, what business do you have with us?”

The mermaid commander’s eyes now turned sharp as they looked up at Lloyd.

She continued to speak. “Speaking of, it is slightly strange. We were only touched by Javier Asrahan’s beautiful appearance, and we allowed his visit

to the kingdom. So it is a mystery why you would come out and gain our affection. Do you have any business with us?”

“Oh, I definitely have.” Lloyd’s face lit up.

“What is it?”

“As I have said briefly, I receive protection from Javier Asrahan. We came here together.”

“So?”

“Since you allowed his visit to your kingdom, I ask that I come along-”

“No.”

“What...?”

“I said no.” Her rejection was clear-cut and sharp. With a sterner gaze, she asked, “What touched us was the beautiful face of Javier Asrahan. So why should we allow your visit to the kingdom when you have no connection with his appearance?”

“Oh... That’s...” Lloyd gulped dryly.

Come on...

Lloyd was secretly flustered. It never occurred to him that he’d be treated this coldly. At last, he understood what was going on.

She’s discriminating against me for my looks!

It looked like Javier was the only one who was permitted to enter. There didn’t seem to be a great reason for it either.

He’s good-looking. That’s the only reason. Fine. Sorry that I’m not good-looking. Sorry that I look like this! Hmph.

Lloyd was resentful and envious. He began to tear up from his anger directed at all the handsome men in the world. But he couldn't just sit back. He elbowed Javier's side and whispered, "Hey."

"Yes," Javier casually answered when he was called.

"Back me up," whispered Lloyd.

"How should I back you up?"

"Anything. Just make sure that I can visit their kingdom too."

"Understood, Young Master."

Javier nodded and stepped forward out of the railing. Lloyd waited with bated breath for what Javier might say. He prayed that the latter would offer some strong words and persuade the mermaids to give him permission to visit their kingdom.

Please!

While Lloyd prayed so, Javier began to speak.

"Commander? I have a favor to ask you."

"Oh! You do?! What is it?"

Contrary to the conversation with Lloyd a moment ago, her voice was now sweet and gentle as she answered Javier. Even her eyes glimmered. Lloyd gave a snort when he saw the difference in her attitude. Meanwhile, Javier and the mermaid continued to converse.

"I would like for you to approve Master Lloyd's visit to your kingdom," gently said Javier.

"Of course. Since you are asking, I will grant it."

With great ease and as if it was the obvious course of action, the mermaid commander flashed a big grin and nodded.

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Chapter 258: The Affairs of the Mermaid Kingdom (2)

“Of course. Since you are asking, I will grant it.”

With great ease and as if it was the obvious course of action, the mermaid commander flashed a big grin and nodded.

That’s it?!

That really was it. That concluded Javier’s request and gained the mermaid guard commander’s approval. There was nothing else expected from him. Javier didn’t even have to use flowery words while making his request or provide any explanations. Nor did he have to desperately expound his situation or give a solid promise in return. It was all left unsaid. Even the reaction of the mermaid guard commander was simple, as though that was the way it should be. She didn’t bother saying anything more and skipped the entire negotiation process.

Dammit. I can do my best, but I’ll never compare against a handsome bastard...

Lloyd berated his life as a growing sense of insecurity gripped him. If they used his usual method, he’d have needed to go through the tiring process of making countless plans and preparations in order to gain permission to visit the Mermaid Kingdom. But when Javier took charge, the whole process became unnecessary.

What the heck? What the heck was that? Please help us. Yes, I will help you since it’s coming from you, Sir Asrahan. Tee-hee. And that was it?

Lloyd felt bitter. The very core of his soul was dismayed. He jumped into the sea, received the clam necklace for visitors, which enabled underwater breathing, talking, protection from water pressure, decompression sickness prevention, and defense from cold, and was safely guided into the deep part of the sea. And throughout all of it, he had tears saltier than the sea running down his face while he followed Javier.

Well, still, I got what I wanted at the end of the day.

Even though the process was unexpectedly uglier than he thought as he sorely learned how perfect Javier was down to his pores, Lloyd achieved exactly what he wanted.

At last, I'm entering the Mermaid Kingdom.

Lloyd clenched his fists and looked around. He saw Javier swimming by his side and the dozens of muscular mermaids guarding them, as well as the sunlight streaming down from the surface of the water like a curtain. The scene looked like something from an incredible dream.

Ha. Is this why he said he wants to reincarnate as a whale?

Just then, Lloyd remembered the Ghost Frontera, how he wanted to be born as a whale again and swim freely across the vast sea. Lloyd could understand what he was talking about.

Meanwhile, they ruthlessly ventured into deeper water. Darkness crept in until all the sunlight vanished around them. Their view became completely pitch black. Just then, Javier moved his hand.

Bzzt…! The aura at his fingertip lit their surroundings like a lantern, allowing Lloyd to swim further in the pitch darkness. And after they traveled about 6,500 to 9,800 feet down the water, or maybe deeper than that, they arrived at the Mermaid Kingdom.

An octopus?

The first thing that came into Lloyd's view was a humongous octopus. But not just any kind. The trunk of its body stretched over a few miles long, and he couldn't picture how gigantic its spread-out legs would be. The largest creatures he had seen until now, the Gigatitan, Bibeong, and the Bone Dragon, would look like a sparrow beside this octopus. Now, it was embracing something that looked like grapes.

Is that... an octopus egg?

At first, Lloyd thought it was the octopus egg he had seen in a TV documentary a few times. But upon closer look, he realized it wasn’t.

It’s a city.

Its brood case was completely empty. No, it was filled with countless buildings.

I wonder if each egg acts as a single living quarter.

In other words, the Mermaid Kingdom was structured like a bunch of grapes embraced by a giant octopus. They were hundreds of square feet large and thousands in number. Could it be that it noticed Lloyd’s admiration?

“It’s all right,” said the mermaid guard commander as she neared Lloyd. “The octopus doesn’t bite. It’s the baby of our kingdom.”

“…”

Their baby? How? Lloyd had a lot of things to say, but he kept silent as they were not kind words. Then they slipped by the trunk of the octopus, safely passing its watchful eye that was as big as a football field. And they entered one egg that served as the entrance to the city before passing and crossing dozens of eggs at the guard commander’s guidance.

“This is where our queen resides. And it’s a rule that visitors must greet the queen and state their business here. And Sir Javier Asrahan?”

“Yes,” said Javier.

“Please have a nice stay here,” said the mermaid with much gentleness.

“Thank you.”

“No, I should be the one to thank you. Well then.”

The guard mermaid had been extremely uptight and cold when she addressed Lloyd. But she was sweet and gentle to Javier. Lloyd scoffed at

her.

Tsk. Lookism can go to hell!

He wanted to leave the kingdom as soon as he could because of the unfair treatment he received at the very least. Lloyd hurried his steps and trudged into the audience room of the queen. The queen was massive and muscular.

Lloyd bowed and said, “I express my infinite gratitude for granting us permission for today’s visit. My name is Lloyd Frontera, a human, and I am honored to be in your presence, my queen. Moreover, I traveled all the way here in search of the Jewel of Truth rumored to be here in the Mermaid Kingdom.” Lloyd quickly revealed his reason for visiting here and waited for her response.

The Jewel of Truth must be an incredibly precious jewel here too if I follow the words of the dragon king. So it’s likely that they won’t easily give it out or let me use it. They might set some big conditions. For instance, demanding some sort of help for the kingdom or a large payment. I’m sure that’s what will happen.

That probably was the case. Lloyd was certain that he’d have to negotiate.

Here comes the important part. I need to figure out what the queen wants and lacks.

The start of negotiation would begin with understanding the needs of another party and capitalizing on their deficits. This strategy promised big returns while minimizing the price of the exchange. Lloyd was sure he’d be able to pull it off this time as well. So he put his mind into focus and carefully waited for the queen’s reaction. But the queen’s reaction was nothing like he had expected.

“What?” gasped the queen in dismay. “The Jewel of Truth? I did not know there was still someone naive enough to believe in that these days.”

“Excuse me...?”

The unexpected laughter from her made Lloyd lift his head without thinking and meet her gaze. At that moment, he felt the meaning of her wide smirk. There was something strange about her smile.

What's that reaction?

An uneasy feeling gripped Lloyd. That wasn't the reaction he expected.

This feels like seeing a foreign journalist coming to the Incheon airport and revealing his purpose of visiting Korea. To hold the interview with the bear who became a human after eating garlic and mugwort. That's the way the queen is looking at me. She has the same gaze as that Korean person staring at the foreign journalist.

At first, Lloyd denied it. There was no way, he said. But it turned out to be true. He observed her, and she was indeed looking at him like that.

No way... The Jewel of Truth can't be a fictional treasure. It can't really only exist in legends, can it?

Inexplicable anxiety crept up in Lloyd. Legendary objects and treasures existed everywhere across the world in any region. There was Cheonbuin, the three divine items of the Dangun myth, and Gan Jian and Moye from the Warring States Period in China. The Kurikara of the Akalnatha in Buddhism. The Excalibur of King Arthur. The dragon-slaying Ascalon in Christianity. Gungnir of Odin in Northern Europe. Brahmastra of the Indian myth. And there was the case of overpackaged snacks in Korea that appeared to be full but were empty when opened. By and large, all of these legendary items had one commonality. They existed only in the realm of imagination and didn't exist in real life. Even if they did exist, they did so a bazillion years ago. In other words, they were impossible to find.

Gripped with a bad feeling, Lloyd asked, "May I ask a question to the queen of the great merpeople?"

"Ask," allowed the queen.

“What you just told me, my queen, about my naivety for believing in the Jewel of Truth... Did you mean that it existed only in stories?”

“What else?”

Although Lloyd’s question was full of nervousness, the queen gave her answer as if that was obvious. She then chuckled and sent a dumbstruck and pitiful gaze at Lloyd.

“You are right,” she said. “The thing about the Jewel of Truth you wish to find is something that I cannot say does not exist. But if you ask me whether I can find it, well. Instead, I want to ask if you belong in a different time period.”

“You mean...”

“The Jewel of Truth exists only in legends and myths even to us,” she continued.

“Agh.” Lloyd choked on some seawater in shock. His uneasy feeling was right.

Dammit! So, it doesn’t exist in real life?

Lloyd was hopeful until he revealed his visiting reason to the queen. But after seeing her reaction, it appeared that this Jewel of Truth was an item of ancient times.

“Um,” went on Lloyd, “Please allow me one more question. Did it ever exist in real life?”

“Um, maybe?” There was uncertainty in her voice.

“What do you mean?” asked Lloyd.

The queen shrugged. “It should be real, I think. But as I told you, perhaps in the mythical ages.”

“Mythical ages...” mumbled Lloyd.

“A shame, isn’t it? You should have been born earlier if you wanted to find it. Don’t you think?”

“...”

Lloyd was utterly speechless. Hearing her, he realized that it wasn’t just the past. It was far back in the mythical ages. So, when he estimated the period through the chronicle mentioned several times in the novel...

It was at least 10,000 years ago.

Lloyd wanted to pass out. The Korean equivalent was even before the time when Dangun founded the Gojoseon. There was no chance of locating an ancient item that hadn’t been seen by the merpeople at the bottom of this vast sea since the mythical ages.

It’s not like I’m an archeologist or anything similar.

Lloyd heaved a sigh. Everything turned bleak for him.

The queen spoke, her voice regretful. “I am sorry that you had to travel all the way down here for such a hopeless answer. But where did you hear the story about the Jewel of Truth? The story is hardly known by those outside of us.”

“Oh... That’s...” Lloyd lifted his head. Berating the very person who taught him about it, Lloyd replied, “From Dragon King Verkis.”

“The dragon king?” shrilled the queen. “Ha. He should be well enough to know about that. And the truth about how it only exists in myths. It appears that you have been played. Is that right?”

“It seems I was in all respects...” Lloyd smiled bitterly. She was right. He had been played by Verkis.

Verkis must have tricked me, so he can send me away. That way I wouldn't badger him anymore.

Now, Lloyd realized what Verkis did to him. Verkis intentionally gave a cursory, half-hearted answer to get rid of him because he wouldn't stop pestering the former with questions. And since Lloyd had no way of checking the truth of his claim, he traveled all the way down here thinking it was real.

Haah. What should I do now?

Truth be told, Lloyd wanted to fly back to the Frontera fiefdom at this very moment and grab Verkis by the collar and shake him. But he had put too much effort into coming all the way here.

Plus, she didn't say that it was all fake.

Maybe. Perhaps. A trace of it could be discovered. Did he think so because he couldn't move on? It didn't matter. He had to stay here for a few days and dig around before he left this kingdom.

"My queen of the great mermaids. May I be granted one favor?" said Lloyd politely.

"A favor?"

"Yes. May I be permitted to stay a few days here to search for the Jewel of Truth?"

"Hmm."

"Please."

Lloyd looked at her earnestly. The queen looked at her annoyingly. At last, she nodded.

"Well, fine. You won't be harming the kingdom with that request anyway."

"Thank you so much!"

"There is no possibility that you will find anything, but in case you do, it only benefits us. Let me make one thing clear. We will not give assistance

to your search. Right now, there's an issue troubling us that needs our attention instead of this miscellaneous matter of yours," said the queen.

"Pardon? An issue?" Lloyd asked again.

The queen frowned. "Yes, something like that. To summarize, the Gate of Hell suddenly appeared in the Arctic Ocean."

"..."

Flinch! The back of Lloyd's neck tightened.

"By any chance, do you know what caused it to open? Did you hear any rumors about it from the human world?"

"No. I didn't."

"Really?"

"Yes." Lloyd's conscience pricked his heart. But he quietly ignored it and nodded at lightning speed. Deciding to shamelessly layer his face with a thick plate of titanium, he spoke.

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Chapter 259: The Affairs of the Mermaid Kingdom (3)

“It must be very concerning for you that the gates to Hell opened over the sea without any warning,” Lloyd shamelessly said.

The frown on her face deepened. “Concerned? Of course, I am. Furthermore, before that incident happened, the Arctic Ocean was the most peaceful ocean in the whole world.”

“What do you mean by that incident?” inquired Lloyd with curiosity.

“The Bone Dragon invasion.” Her voice sank as though the event still haunted her.

“Eek.”

Lloyd almost shot out a gush of seawater as he breathed then, but he managed to mask his shock by shutting his mouth. The queen continued to speak with a sigh.

“It happened not too long ago. The peaceful sea was thrown into chaos. It was definitely an invasion. An invasion by the Bone Dragon, an unprecedented existence.”

“The Bone Dragon...”

Lloyd gulped dryly. An appearance of the Bone Dragon in the Arctic Ocean. Moreover, it had happened recently. It had to be Draggy. There was no other possibility.

I opened Hell Gate about the time the queen experienced all this. It opened up right here in the sky. And Draggy, who was lingering around the Arctic Ocean, crossed over to Hell through it and helped fight the Lava Giant. It matches. The story matches perfectly.

Lloyd unwittingly shrugged. His conscience was prickling, and a sense of crisis overwhelmed him. He wondered what would happen to him if the

queen found out he was responsible for sending Draggy here.

There's no doubt that she would execute me.

He wouldn't be able to get out of here in one piece. It was true regardless of if he was under Javier's protection. Javier wouldn't be able to endure for long without the help of magic in this deep sea. Lloyd became more convinced when he saw the muscular build of the mermaids. Even as Lloyd kept dryly swallowing in anxiety, the queen continued to speak.

"I cannot go over the details, but the Bone Dragon invaded our territory. It even made the Gigatitan and emperor whales run away in chaos."

"So were the Mermaid Corps employed?" Lloyd maintained his cool.

"Of course." Could she be recalling the event of the day? Her gaze grew icy. "We attacked day and night. It was a bloody fight. We were fighting for days when the Hell Gate opened up in the sky."

Lloyd felt a pang of guilt as he listened.

"It appears that our attacks took a toll on the Bone Dragon," she went on. "The moment it saw the gate open, it frantically ran off into the gate."

Lloyd had a lot to say, such as how Draggy only flew into the gate because it was happy to pick his smell, but he zipped his mouth shut.

"Long story short, the gate has remained open in the air after that incident. So, I am troubled as the hot air from Hell constantly flows into this world."

"That... is really problematic." Lloyd smiled wryly. It indeed sounded like a pickle on the queen's part.

The gate is allowing heat to enter here... Hmm. That must have increased the temperature in this area. Now that I think about it, the title I received from Hell didn't even get activated when I got here.

Just then, the title "Frozen Feet, Frozen Hands" he had received from Hell came to his mind.

It activates when I set foot in areas with annual temperatures below 32°F.

But the title didn’t activate when he arrived in the Arctic Ocean. In other words, the annual temperature wasn’t falling below 32°F.

Hmm... I wonder if the Arctic is experiencing an unexpected bout of global warming right now.

Lloyd was troubled. Unwittingly, he’s become a culprit for environmental destruction. But he didn’t know how to fix that.

The King of Hell wants to keep the gate open like it is now.

So the gate was unlikely to close any time soon. It was to remain open as it is for the unforeseeable future. This bout of global warming was expected to last here.

Tsk.

Even though Lloyd didn’t choose this place on purpose, he nonetheless felt apologetic for the polar bears and merpeople in this area. However, he soon fixed the expression on his face.

If she finds out that I did it, I’m dead.

The uproar with Draggy and the Hell Gate. All these incidents were connected with Lloyd, so there wasn’t any good for him to have the queen find that out.

I should try to survive before anything else. I have to be alive to be able to help them out and fix this problem.

And it would be even better if the mermaids somehow solved this problem with the Hell Gate on their own before he did. Thinking so, Lloyd shamelessly justified himself and empathized with the queen.

“Haah,” he sighed, “I understand. You must be very concerned.”

“I am,” said the queen, her voice heavy. “In particular, the glaciers are melting fast. My head is about to explode, hearing the complaints and protests of various creatures. I did not know being a ruler would be this difficult. It would be easier to jump rope with 20 emperor whales for 12 hours straight without breathing.”

“I-is that so...” murmured Lloyd.

“Yes, sincerely. If only I could find the culprit behind this mess. I would lay a hard punch into their gut, taking out all of the stress and anger that has been building inside me.”

Lloyd blanched at the warning, his face going pale as a sheet.

“Why do you look like that?” the queen said after observing Lloyd’s face. “You look pale. Are you still not used to breathing underwater?”

“Nothing. Just for a second... I was...” Lloyd stopped.

“You were what?”

“This is random, but the honeypots I’d left behind at home just came to my mind,” Lloyd said carefully, inwardly thinking that he should enjoy his honey before he passed away. To Lloyd’s relief, it appeared that the queen didn’t catch on.

“Honey? I have heard that it’s a sweet produce made on land. I wish to get a taste of it when I have the chance,” she said. “Anyway, you can go now. I will permit you to go around the kingdom as I have said earlier.”

“Thank you so much!”

Lloyd quickly bowed and disappeared from the queen’s view. He feared she’d start to notice something if he unnecessarily hovered around longer. As soon as he removed himself from her presence, he let out the breath he’d been holding in until now.

“Haah...”

I made it, Lloyd said to himself. Just then, he felt a prickling gaze coming from someone beside him. He turned and stared at Javier with a bitter smile.

“Why are you looking at me like that? You aren’t questioning my conscience or something with that look you’re giving me, right?”

“Why else?” Javier replied, almost in a rebuking tone. “It’s impossible for you to say that you have nothing to do with the Hell Gate’s appearance and Draggy running amok here.”

“Well, you’re right. But what can I do? I have to survive before anything else. Didn’t you see the abs on the queen back there?” Lloyd sighed.

“I did see it.”

“And yet, you have the heart to say that? Must I get crushed by her muscular embrace for you to be satisfied ?”

“Yes.” Javier gave a thumbs up.

“What? Seriously?” said Lloyd, shooting a look at Javier.

“Yes, those are my honest feelings,” Javier announced confidently.

“So, you would really feel better after seeing me get crushed to death?”

“For anyone who abandons their conscience and integrity can only live a life of a coward.”

“Why, yes, thank you. I’ll live a long life as a coward.”

Seeing that Javier wasn’t answering, Lloyd chuckled. “But Master Lloyd.” When Javier spoke again, his face was grim.

“Yeah.”

“Is there really a reason you had to come all the way here to find the supposed Jewel of Truth?” asked Javier.

“Um, maybe?” Lloyd shrugged, and he thought to himself that the moment had finally come.

Okay. Yeah, it’s about time that he starts to ask questions.

Lloyd stole a glance at Javier walking beside him. He couldn’t know. The terrible events that would land on the Frontera family. The death of Count and Countess Frontera and Julian. The utter downfall of the family. This world was going through the same events as the novel.

That’s the effect of the restoration of destiny. Goodness.

Lloyd shuddered in annoyance as he thought about it. He had worked hard to change the dreadful plot at the start of the novel. There was no end to the amount of blood, sweat, and tears he went through until now!

But it will eventually end up being for nothing. That’s all because of the moronic restoration of destiny or whatever it’s called.

Lloyd thought the whole situation was unfair. But he couldn’t sit down and wail about it. He had to do something to prevent this damned catastrophe from happening. He had to find a way to stop it. And that was why he needed to find the Jewel of Truth which held the answer to any question it was asked.

But I can’t tell this man everything.

The original history. The altered storyline. The return of destiny to its initial path. Lloyd would have to uncover his identity to explain it all to Javier, including that he wasn’t the real Lloyd. That he was a fake from another world who took the place of the real person. Everything would need to be revealed.

I can’t do that.

Lloyd shook his head immediately. Now was the time to lie. And there was a perfect lie he had prepared for a situation like this.

“Um, you see, the thing about the Jewel of Truth,” Lloyd said as he licked his lips before pausing. And in a nonchalant voice, he said the remark he had prepared beforehand. “It’s a form of insurance.”

“Insurance...?”

“Yeah.” Lloyd nodded, feigning his conviction. “You know how I’m waking the dragon king up every morning? I heard it from him by chance.”

“That the jewel is here in the kingdom?” inquired Javier.

“Yeah. I heard it’s a powerful jewel.”

“What power does it carry?”

“It has the answer to even the most difficult question in the world.” Lloyd continued to walk as he talked.

“An answer?”

“Yeah. There’s a chance of encountering a difficult problem as you go through life, right? For example, the Monster Domino effect. Do you remember it? The swarm of locusts that chased us.”

“I do remember,” said Javier with a nod.

“There’s no guarantee that such a thing will never happen again.” Lloyd looked straight into Javier’s eyes.

“So, what you are saying is, Master Lloyd, you are looking for the jewel in preparation for a disaster that will fall on the fiefdom?” summed up Javier.

“That’s right. That is exactly right.” Lloyd nodded casually. And he continued to lie. “Life is long. You never know what calamities will come. But what if we have the jewel in our hands before they hit us? I’ll be able to safely overcome them, at least once. So? Don’t you think it’s a pretty good form of insurance?”

“Truly. It is.”

“That’s what I thought,” said Lloyd as he brought his hands to his back.

“Yes,” said Javier.

“But I’m surprised that you’re nodding to what I say without a fight. What’s going on?” Lloyd said with a smile.

With a straight face, Javier looked at Lloyd. “I believe that even the most messed up man can speak something right once in a while.”

“What?” gaped Lloyd.

“So, acknowledging and encouraging the messed-up man when he says the right thing is a beautiful consideration a person like me can show.”

“Woah,” replied Lloyd with utter disbelief.

“This is the first time in a while that I heard you say something right. Good job, Master Lloyd.”

“Wow.” Lloyd stopped walking. “I see you’ve stooped down to attacking people with compliments now.”

“Like I always say,” replied Javier as he followed suit, “I’ve never been violent toward you, Master Lloyd. I do not plan on it in the future, either.”

Lloyd turned and continued to walk. “Tsk. You know, I wouldn’t hate you so much if you didn’t talk back.”

“Thank you for hating me.”

“Then should I keep it up from now on?” asked Lloyd.

“Thank you in advance for that as well.”

“Gratitude comes in advance now?”

“If I could, I wish to offer mine all at once.”

“Do you not want to offer it in parts?”

“Yes. That way I will not have to thank you in the future.”

“Wow! You know what? You be the young master. I’ll be the guard,” Lloyd exclaimed in a high-pitched voice.

“Okay now, Sir Frontera.”

“Hey.” Lloyd looked genuinely offended.

“Please forgive me,” Javier said, backing down immediately.

“Yet, you’re still smiling.”

“Since it was indeed amusing.”

“Fine, if you were pleased. What else can I ask for more,” chuckled Lloyd. And he thought to himself...

Whew.

Javier bought his seemingly believable lie. Lloyd was actually worried that his reasoning, that he was here to find the jewel in preparation for a future disaster, would not be persuasive enough.

But for now, it worked. I’m off the hook for a while.

Lloyd inwardly sighed in relief. Meanwhile, Javier stole a glance at Lloyd with a serious gaze and thought to himself...

It’s a relief.

Javier’s reaction was all an act, but Lloyd bought it. He was actually worried about whether he would be able to hide his knowledge of the whole situation.

But Master Lloyd, no, that fraud doesn’t have a clue that I know. He mustn’t know yet that my reaction was an act, and I’m just playing along to his

hardly convincing excuse. I'm off the hook for a while.

Then Javier would be able to protect the fake in relief. And help out what the fake was up to. Just like that, Javier smiled meaningfully. The two then got out of the palace premise and passed through a few strands of passages before entering the city that looked like a giant grape.

Woah. I'm craving salted pollack roe.

The image of the city, thousands and tens of thousands of dozens-foot large eggs stuck to each other, stimulated Lloyd's appetite. The city made him miss the food back home. The salted pollack roe, which was his favorite, was the biggest craving of all.

Whew. Pour a bowl of bibimbap with wild chive soy sauce and throw in some salted pollack roe and top it with perilla oil and sesame seed and seaweed... Wow. I'm going nuts.

A pang of nostalgia assaulted Lloyd's mind, making him salivate. But he knew he had better things to do than space out.

First, I'll look for the jewel.

Lloyd resolved and looked around the city district of the Mermaid Kingdom, his gaze filled with determination. Countless muscular merpeople were swimming around.

One of them must know about the jewel for sure!

Lloyd hoped so. After all, that was the legendary jewel of the kingdom. A mythical item, a precious one, even if that was the item of the past. He figured that they should know one or two things about it.

So, I'll be going around asking as many merpeople as I can. Then I can put all their answers together and find some hope. Or, at least, I'll be able to get a clue as to how I can track the jewel.

That was what Lloyd intended to do. Plus, he was confident. No biggie. A simple task. So, he approached merfolks, brimming with confidence. But

sometime later, Lloyd started to receive the same treatment as the cults that go around soliciting people on the streets.

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Chapter 260: Do You Know About the Jewel? (1)

“Excuse me, have you ever heard of the Jewel of Truth?”

“...”

The 840,928th egg was at the center of the strange but humongous city in the Mermaid Kingdom, composed of hundreds and thousands of eggs. It sat at the deepest part of the Arctic Ocean. The residents of this area, otherwise known as the “Red Egg,” found themselves encountering an eccentric foreigner.

“The Jewel of Truth?” The mermaid who heard the question bulged her pecs, wondering what the heck this human was saying. She stared intensely at the stranger, Lloyd, who awkwardly swam in place before flashing a smile.

“Oh, please don’t think of me strangely,” Lloyd explained. “I just heard an interesting rumor from the human world. I came all the way down here because I heard that there is a remarkable treasure called the Jewel of Truth.”

“Hmph,” puffed the mermaid, “That’s an ancient rumor.”

“Excuse me?”

“That’s such an old story...” The mermaid sent a baffling gaze at Lloyd, and she was already about five gills away from him.

“I only heard of it in passing when I was a child. Sorry.”

“Oh, please wait a minute…!”

The mermaid dashed away from Lloyd before he had any chance to stop her, her gills working faster than earlier.

“Haah,” Lloyd sighed.

This... This feels weird.

Their reactions were slightly different from what he expected. Originally, since the Jewel of Truth was one of the precious jewels of the kingdom and existed in their myths and legends, he assumed that the merpeople would be familiar with it. As such, he anticipated easily getting an answer from any passing merperson.

Of course, I didn't expect all their answers to be useful. I thought that once I put them all together, I'd be able to find some sort of clue or lead. But this is just...

Their reaction was the complete opposite of his expectations. Almost all the merpeople reacted cynically to his question. Some were even...

"Excuse me, do you know anything about the Jewel of Truth?" Lloyd asked a merperson passing by.

"No, I don't. I really don't," the mermaid swayed in irritation.

"Do you really not know?"

"Oh, don't hold me back. I have to swim. It's not like you'll take responsibility if I lose my muscles because you stopped me from swimming."

This kind of blatant disrespect toward him was a common occurrence. In other words, this was...

I'm being treated like those cult members who poach people in public!

Lloyd sighed at length. Surely enough, everyone's reaction told of his existence to them. They acted like they were being held back to answer a useless question in their busy schedule. They blatantly showed their annoyance. Still, even that could be considered a mild reaction compared to others.

"My, Ma'am, where are you so busy going?" Lloyd asked another mermaid.

“Hmm? What’s a human from above water doing here?”

“Oh, well, the thing is, I am looking for a treasure called the Jewel of Truth here. And you appeared at a perfect time. I can’t believe I ran into such a wise-looking mermaid like you. Could you spare me a few minutes to answer a few questions-”

“No,” the mermaid rejected flatly.

“...”

“I’m already going nuts from my aching bones. I don’t give a damn about your questions.”

“Um, but still-”

“Still, my foot. You young, dumb human. You’re a scammer, right?”

“Excuse me?” Lloyd stared, aghast.

“How can the Jewel of Truth exist in our day and age? I’d have entertained you if it was 10,000 years ago when the seasons of fall and winter didn’t exist. You’re bringing up crap that’s older than the dentures of my great, great, great grandmother. It’s not something a human child like you should care about.”

“...”

“So, young man. What are you really up to? What kind of scam are you trying to pull off, asking around about the Jewel of Truth and whatnot?”

“Um...”

“Answer me now!” snarled the old mermaid. “Do you want a spanking from me?!”

Flare! The mermaid grandmother growled menacingly. Though her back was slightly curved, her forearms looked terrorizing. She seemed strong

enough to easily snap five quarter dollars in half as her regular morning workout. Lloyd was in dismay.

Haah. I don't know what to tell her.

Lloyd wanted to cry. All this time, he was receiving icy stares from passing merpeople, and some of the elderly nearby even tried to spank Lloyd when he acted in the slightest ill-mannered way.

"Eek! Please forgive me! I am sorry!" Eventually, Lloyd bowed several times and scooted off. And as he caught his breath in the corner of an alley, a surge of bitterness arose in him.

Wow. This is just nuts.

Dumbstruck, a snort escaped him.

This feels like I'm going around Seoul asking people where I could find a wolf pretending to be an old lady in Little Red Riding Hood.

That was how they reacted. The Jewel of Truth of the Mermaid Kingdom. Now, Lloyd could sorely feel what an ancient treasure it was.

Should I give up and go back?

He considered going back home and clinging onto Dragon King Verkis, who had played him. That looked like a better course of action. Another option was traveling to Hell and asking the Hell of King about how he could stop destiny from restoring, even if it came with a price. But he soon shook his head.

No. I went out of my way to come all the way down here!

It was too much of a waste to pack up and go back. He felt that he should stick around for about a day or two longer. If nothing useful was found, then he would go back. From that moment on, he acted more shamelessly as he went around questioning anyone he could find despite the cold treatment and disrespect he received from the merpeople.

“Excuse me? Have you ever heard of the Jewel of Truth?”

“...”

“There! Over there with the awesome biceps! Are you interested in the Jewel of Truth?”

“...”

“Oh, you have the most beautiful gill among the mermaids I’ve seen today. Anyhow, have you ever heard of the Jewel of Truth?”

“...”

Not a single one of them reacted nicely. They all treated him like how Koreans reacted to cult members on the streets. That is, with a gaze that said, “What in the bullcrap are you talking about?” Then walking away after ignoring him. But Lloyd was relentless. He was neither disappointed nor discouraged. The cold disregard and disrespect were something he experienced often back in Korea when he was shabbily dressed and at the bottom of the social pyramid. Experiencing that again was nothing to fuss over at all. It was nothing new. On the contrary, he just became more brazen.

Whatever. If they’re going to regard me as if I’m a cult member, then I might well just act like one.

At last, Lloyd made the decision. Since he couldn’t avoid it, he would go all out. It was time to embody a cult recruiter and draw everyone’s attention.

“Excuse me, ma’am. My, you look so kind! You look like someone who received an immense amount of positive energy from the Jewel of Truth!”

“...”

“Fellow over there? Don’t your shoulders feel heavy or doesn’t your neck feel tense? Goodness, I’m looking at you now, and your ancestors are on your back crying. They’re saying that you should find the Jewel of Truth at all costs.”

“...”

“Hmm, I don’t know if I can tell you this when I’m just seeing you for the first time, but tell me, aren’t you going through a hard time recently? If you receive energy from the Jewel of Truth, everything will go well for you. I don’t usually tell this to people, but I’m making an exception just for you.”

“...”

Of course, despite this change of strategy, the merpeople still showed the same cold reaction. But there was one thing that was now different.

Great. They are gathering around!

Lloyd discretely clenched his fists. Could it be that the rumor about him and his weird ways went out? Could it be that they started to hear about the human nut-job? They were gathering around in groups and whispering as they watched Lloyd. Some scoffed, while some erupted into laughter. The atmosphere of the crowd was that of people watching a fascinating or silly scene. Lloyd, however, felt no shame despite all this.

Great. This is much better than before.

Now, he was starting to grow more hopeful. It wasn’t that they were responding now. It was only that he succeeded in gaining traction and gathering a fairly large audience.

This is a matter of probability, so to speak.

The chances of getting an answer would increase if he could gather hundreds of merpeople at once instead of asking one of them at a time.

Though Javier is embarrassed on my behalf.

Javier had been blushing crimson since a while ago. He couldn’t even lift his head up. Could it be that he was ashamed of Lloyd? Was he trying to signal to everybody that this human was a stranger to him? Whatever the reason was, his shame was evident. He couldn’t get himself to move far away but timidly stayed five steps away from him. Lloyd grinned.

So, the game is on.

From then on, Lloyd talked louder and asked questions about the Jewel of Truth, so that every merperson gathered nearby could hear him. He shamelessly shouted in full force, hoping that any interested merperson would speak out. That was what he was doing when...

“Excuse me, are you really curious about the Jewel of Truth?”

For the first time, a merman came and asked Lloyd a question!

“Eh?” Shocked, Lloyd stared at the merman.

It was a young merman with eye-catching light blue hair. But his looks were a bit unique.

He’s not that muscular for a merman.

Unlike the common muscular build, this merman was different. He had the body of a track athlete, slim. And he was sending a serious gaze at Lloyd.

“Actually, I’ve heard you speaking since a while ago. I mean the questions you’ve been asking other merpeople.”

“You’ve heard my questions?” asked Lloyd in surprise.

“Yes.” The merman nodded slightly. And in a much more serious voice, he said, “So, I would like to have a serious conversation with you about the Jewel of Truth. Do you mind if we move somewhere else? Somewhere less crowded.”

“I’d like that,” Lloyd pleasingly agreed with a nod.

Yes, this was the moment he had been waiting for all this time. He and Javier followed the slim merman. They all swam away until they arrived in a less populated area.

The merman turned and said, “It is nice to meet you. My name is Rotorua.”

“Rotorua?” Lloyd repeated the name instead of greeting himself as he was still in a daze.

“That’s right. My mother got the name from the most famous mermaid of the mythical age. She did so in the hopes that I would retrieve the most precious treasure of that time period, the Jewel of Truth.” Merman Rotorua spoke with a grave look on his face.

Lloyd lifted his brow. “You’re looking for an artifact of the mythical age? The Jewel of Truth?”

“Yes.” Rotorua nodded. “To be honest, my family has devoted all our lives to unearthing the Jewel of Truth for several generations. They have been doing so for thousands of years. But we have not succeeded yet. Then recently I heard the news of a human swimming around asking strange questions.”

“It was about me,” pointed Lloyd.

“That is why I hurriedly swam over here.” A faint smile bloomed Rotorua’s face which had remained serious until then. It manifested the surprise and admiration he felt earlier.

I never expected to meet a human who believes in the Jewel of Truth.

He was more than pleased about it and couldn’t be any happier. The reason for his happiness was simple.

Even the merpeople have nearly forgotten about the Jewel of Truth. However, it’s the most regrettable part of our heritage that we have lost.

Rotorua has believed for the longest time that it must be retrieved. That was why he devoted his whole life searching for it. But he never got any of his folks to cooperate with him. Instead, he was mocked all this time for being unmerman-like. A true merperson did not fuss over the artifact. He was told a proper merperson should care about swimming and building more muscles instead of going out searching for a boring jewel. Rotorua had been lashed out and slapped down all this time. But today, he met someone who

was on the same page as him. The Jewel of Truth was something that even merpeople overlooked. Yet, he finally met someone who was as desperate to find the treasure as him! But it was not a merperson but a human! Deeply moved, Rotorua grabbed Lloyd's hands as his shoulders shivered in excitement.

"So, I would like to ask for a favor if it is not too much from a stranger like me."

"What favor?" asked Lloyd.

With his eyes glimmering in sheer earnestness, Rotorua asked, "How about you and I work together to find the Jewel of Truth?"

Rotorua didn't care if his expedition partner wasn't his kind or a different race. That didn't matter as long as he had a companion to search for the jewel with. He was merely happy to work with someone like him. Just then…

"Hmm," mused Lloyd. "I don't know." He cocked his head to the side and sent a doubting gaze at Rotorua before saying, "The thing is, I don't know how much I should trust you."

"What...?" His words flustered Rotorua. This human man was looking for the Jewel of Truth. So Rotorua naturally presumed that his request would be accepted instead of receiving such a snobby and reluctant reaction.

"Is it not?" Lloyd continued to voice out his doubt. "Put yourself in my shoes. The others are busy ignoring me in annoyance, and yet, you came on your own to find me. How should I know whether you have something up your sleeves? Am I supposed to happily take your offer without a second thought?"

"Oh, what are you talking-"

"I'm saying," put in Lloyd, "What if you're a scammer with bad intentions? Don't you think it'd be easy for you to prey on my desperate, innocent

heart, which has been tattered after running around for an answer but to no avail?”

“H-hey. I’m not the kind of merperson that preys on someone’s desp-”

“Then prove it,” demanded Lloyd as he gazed into Rotorua’s eyes.

“...”

“You said your family has been searching for the jewel for generations.”

“I did.” Rotorua frowned, trying to make sense of this whole situation. “But what of it-”

“So, prove that you’re not a scammer.”

“How?”

“Well, how else?” Lloyd said, his voice dripping with humdrumness. “It’s easy. Tell me everything about it. I know a lot about it on my part. I’ll cross-check your knowledge with mine, and I’ll be able to judge if you’re scamming me or being genuine.”

“I-is that how much you can’t trust me?”

“Tsk. You know, you’re free to go if you can’t prove yourself.”

Lloyd then wheeled around. At the sight, Rotorua was provoked. But anxiousness soon overcame his anger.

No!

This was nearly his first time meeting someone who was deeply invested in the jewel. He didn’t want to lose this human. Rotorua hurriedly held out his hand and grabbed Lloyd’s shoulder.

“Then you better listen to me carefully. You see, the Jewel of Truth has been passed down since the mythical age of the Mermaid Kingdom...”

From then on, Rotorua began to reel off everything about the jewel, antsy and annoyed at the same time. He missed the evil smile that hung on Lloyd's face as he tried to prove his innocence. It never occurred to him that Lloyd, whose back was against Rotorua, was smiling like a man who succeeded in catching a fish with his bait.

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Chapter 261: Do You Know the Jewel? (2)

“Are all people on land like this?” grumbled Rotorua as he stomped his feet in frustration. “How can you have so little faith in others? Now open your ears and listen to me. I will prove that I am not lying about the Jewel of Truth.”

“Sure, sure,” drawled Lloyd, his face bored.

Ignoring his curt attitude, Rotorua started speaking, “The Jewel of Truth is not merely a fictional item that exists in legends.”

Lloyd picked his ear. “Sure, so what?”

Rotorua gazed into Lloyd’s eyes. “It certainly existed at one point in time.”

Lloyd picked his ear. “Sure, so what?”

“T-technically speaking,” Rotorua stammered, “It was certainly in the sea during the second mythical age, that is, the time when spring and summer were the only seasons that existed in the world.”

“Hmm. Is that so?” Lloyd made a curious face.

“That is the truth. Undoubtedly.”

After a pause, Lloyd said, “But, um, so?”

“It really did exist at one point,” emphasized Rotorua.

“Um, so?” asked Lloyd again, fidgeting his fingers.

“Hmm, um, but it disappeared later on. No, it collapsed!”

“Hmm, I see,” said Lloyd without looking up.

“…”

A strong yearning to strike Lloyd overwhelmed Rotorua as his face turned red with anger. His fists unconsciously clenched. If only he could. If only it was harmless, he wanted to hammer the back of this spiteful human just once. But Rotorua mustered a miraculous amount of patience and remembered a lesson from his childhood.

Patience. Patience. I just have to be patient. They say that patience is the secret behind cultivating pearls. It is time to exercise patience now.

It was Rotorua's first time meeting someone who was interested in the Jewel of Truth. That person was this human, Lloyd. Thus, Rotorua couldn't ruin this precious opportunity by his momentary feelings of anger. Controlling his tumultuous rage, he spoke.

"Haah... I will cut to the chase. The Jewel of Truth was not a small object."

Lloyd lifted his brows. "If it wasn't, what was it?"

"It was a building," Rotorua paused before continuing for effect. "The Jewel of Truth was a building that was as much of a treasure as even the shiniest pearl under the sea. Huge, magnificent, and majestic. Though, of course, it fell down at the end of the mythical age."

"Hmm," mused Lloyd.

"Do you trust me now?" inquired Rotorua as he expectantly looked straight into Lloyd's eyes.

"Hmm, I'm not sure." Lloyd's tone reflected his hesitation.

Rotorua frowned.

"The Jewel of Truth was not a small object but a building. Well, that's something anyone can think of with a little effort." Lloyd tapped the side of his head.

"I am not lying," protested Rotorua indignantly, "It is real. Based on some of the records my ancestors excavated and after putting together various interpretations and deductions of artifacts, the Jewel of Truth was a building

without question. I am sure of it. However, it was not just any building. And it surely was not one that merely looked beautiful on the outside."

"Then," asked Lloyd, "What was it?"

"It was a magic circle."

"A magic circle?"

Rotorua nodded. "Every component of the building, that is, from the foundation to the floor, pillar, and ceiling, everything was magically structured. It was one gigantic magic circle."

"Hmm," mused Lloyd as he stroked his jaw. "So, to sum everything up, the Jewel of Truth was a magic circle in the form of a giant building?"

"Exactly."

A faint hopeful smile appeared on Rotorua's face. Rotorua sensed Lloyd was starting to believe and show interest in his words. His story seemed to be getting through to the man, and at last, Lloyd looked like he trusted him. Rotorua swelled with joy and excitement. From that moment on, he began to reel off in full force, his mouth moving like a tube man in a storm.

"It is said that the foundation, floor, pillars, and roofs have been designed according to the flow of magical power. As such, the entire building resembles something close to an intelligent life form."

"An intelligent life form?" repeated Lloyd. This was a surprise.

"A magical entity that can think, reason, and draw logical reasons on its own."

"Hmm."

Lloyd slightly lifted his brow as he listened. Rotorua's explanation reminded him of a concept he was familiar with back in Korea.

Is this something similar to AI?

Lloyd wondered if that building called the Jewel of Truth, which was just one magic circle, could be...

So it was essentially an AI supercomputer, but one that operates with the power of magic.

The building was a supercomputer, but its operation engine didn't come from science and technology. It was powered by magic. This thought soon shed light on what kind of structure it was to Lloyd. And as he continued to hear Rotorua's explanations, he was able to gain a better understanding of the Jewel of Truth.

"Literally speaking," explained Rotorua, "The Jewel of Truth was a building with magical intelligence. It was astute and wise. It was capable of offering clear answers to even the most complicated questions, which ranged from trivial personal matters to dilemmas of great importance that could change the world. The Jewel of Truth provided the most accurate and wisest answer by considering all the truths and facts. And-"

"But," Lloyd chimed in, stopping Rotorua to deal with an important matter, "You say it collapsed out of the blue and disappeared?"

Rotorua nodded, his eyes downcast. "Yes. According to past records, they say that a terrible catastrophe shook the entire world on the last day of the mythical age, and in the wake of it, all the living souls in existence waged a war of survival against each other. The Jewel of Truth was devastated during this time and..."

"It got destroyed?" Lloyd finished Rotorua's words.

"Probably. It is assumed that this was done by those who feared the jewel would fall into the hands of their enemies."

"No surprise there," said Lloyd as he nodded. Lloyd, too, agreed that an all-knowing magical AI supercomputer could make an extremely functional and intimidating piece of weaponry to any holder. It'd be a source of absolute confidence. And during precarious times when everyone was biting each other to survive, that'd be even more true.

Whoever last used the Jewel of Truth must have destroyed it, so no one else can have it and use it themselves.

Lloyd figured he'd have made a similar choice if he were in the same place. When his train of thought reached that far, Lloyd felt his knees weaken with a sense of emptiness.

Anyway, this means that the Jewel of Truth does not exist in this world anymore.

It didn't exist. The incredible smart building that used to exist during the mythical age. Lloyd could see that it had been a mind-blowing creation at the time but was ultimately destroyed. It was no longer in this world. In other words...

Tsk. All my effort was for nothing.

He had taken a tedious trip down to this kingdom. But for what? To discover a nonexistent item. It looked like he had wasted his time.

"I see. Then I will take my leave now," Lloyd said, ready to take off.

"Hmm? What do you mean?" Rotorua, who had been excitedly talking about the Jewel of Truth, stopped, and he shot an incredulous look at Lloyd. "Didn't you say you can't trust me? But that you would go find the jewel if I convinced you otherwise?"

"Sure," acknowledged Lloyd casually, "I did. But then you just told me it was destroyed."

"I did."

"That's why I'm leaving. What's the point of searching for the destroyed jewel? I won't be able to use it anyway."

It really was the case. According to Rotorua, the Jewel of Truth wasn't just a small device but an awe-inspiring building, a supercomputer magic circle. That was what had collapsed. So what good was there in excavating the remaining pieces? It wouldn't be useful anyway.

“You see, I was searching because I want to use the jewel. But it’s destroyed, you say? And given that it was such an intricate magic circle and building, it’ll need to be perfectly restored for it to operate,” pointed out Lloyd in annoyance.

“T-That’s right,” Rotorua acknowledged.

“Right? Plus, we won’t be able to restore the building since the remnant traces would be thousands and thousands of years old. Am I wrong?”

“On that part, you are wrong,” Rotorua said grimly.

“Excuse me...?” When Lloyd saw Rotorua shake his head very firmly, he lifted his brow. “I’m wrong? Then is there a way to restore the Jewel of Truth?”

“Of course there is.”

“How can you be so certain?” said Lloyd, almost in a demanding tone.

“It’s because there is a blueprint of the jewel.”

“There is a blueprint?”

“Yes.”

“Where is it?” Lloyd’s heart started to pound.

Who would’ve thought? There was a blueprint!

Then he wouldn’t have to scavenge around for the jewel. He only needed to thoroughly go through, analyze, and study the blueprint before constructing the building. But Rotorua’s next words killed his excitement.

“The land where the jewel collapsed. One record says that the blueprint was carved into the land the building once stood on,” replied Rotorua.

Lloyd kept listening without saying anything.

“So we must find the land where the jewel sat. I am hopeful that once we find it, the jewel can be restored to its original state. My ancestors were all just as hopeful as me. That is why we devoted our entire lives to this search for hundreds of generations.”

Tsk. Then we still have to find the site the jewel was at.

Lloyd licked his lips.

But still, I guess it’s a relief that it wasn’t all for nothing?

That seemed to be the case after he listened to Rotorua. Though the jewel was destroyed and long gone, its blueprint could be recovered once the site of the building was found. Therefore, with the blueprint, the jewel could be rebuilt one way or another.

Luckily, construction is one thing that I’m familiar with.

Lloyd started to see a ray of hope, and at the same time, he was glad to have doubted and felt Rotorua out.

This merman told me almost everything he knew after feeling wronged by my suspicions.

Rotorua had reeled off everything he knew, allowing Lloyd to conveniently and happily acquire information about the jewel in a breeze. Simultaneously, he was able to recognize Rotorua’s sincerity.

At the very least, I know he isn’t a scammer.

Rotorua had an embittered look on his face that screamed, “I’m innocent!” but any scammer could easily feign the emotion well enough. So it wasn’t his expression that prompted Lloyd to ascertain Rotorua’s innocence. It was the messages that kept appearing in front of his eyes.

Ding dong.

[Merman Rotorua is feeling anxious and disappointed over your snobby attitude and lack of willingness to trust him.]

[Your likeability with Rotorua has decreased by two points.]

[Current RP with Rotorua: +14]

[Even though your relationship with a major character has slightly worsened, your RP remains unchanged and will not be forfeited.]

[Current RP: 2,482]

See? My likeability status with him has already been activated.

A faint smile spread across Lloyd's face as he looked at the messages. His past experiences confirmed the knowledge that his likeability with another character didn't always reward him with RP. The system opened only when the other party was deeply invested in Lloyd. In other words, the likeability message meant only one thing.

It's proof that he's resolved to win my trust and get close to me.

Such a resolution couldn't be established with lies and wouldn't be harbored by a scammer. The system wouldn't have been activated, either, in the first place. Thanks to this, Lloyd was now able to trust Rotorua.

I *was able to get an important confirmation, thanks to my suspicions.*

His smile slightly deepened. He was now able to trust Rotorua and work together with him. This was critical for Lloyd. In a situation related to stopping the restoration of destiny, that was even more so the case.

I've got only three years with me. The count will be the first. And then everyone is going to die one by one. Time is running out, and I can't waste any by being deceived and fooled.

It was imperative for Lloyd to work with someone he could completely trust. There couldn't be any time wasted from getting foolishly scammed or deceived, and that was why Lloyd intentionally raised his suspicions. He proceeded with great caution when engaging with Roturua and didn't hide his doubts. He, instead, used his doubts to pressure the merman, which eventually allowed him to confirm the latter's sincerity.

“So, if what you are saying is true, I just need to find the location of the jewel, right?” asked Lloyd meaningfully.

“You are right. That is exactly right.” Rotorua’s face lit up at Lloyd’s question. “Then do you trust me now? Are you going to join me in excavating the jewel?”

“Um, maybe...” responded Lloyd with hesitation.

Disappointment filled Rotorua’s eyes. “What do you mean?”

“I would first like to hear about your excavation method,” said Lloyd, “You said that your family has been working tirelessly for hundreds of generations on this search.”

“That is right.”

“But despite such extensive years, you have not found the land yet.”

“T-that’s right,” Rotorua acknowledged.

“So it’s only natural for me to have some doubts.” Lloyd looked straight into Rotorua’s eyes for emphasis.

“Doubts?”

“What inefficient method has your family been using to fail in finding a piece of land for hundreds of generations?”

“That’s-”

“That’s what?” put in Lloyd.

“We simply dug to the best of our abilities.” Rotorua scratched the back of his head.

“Dug?”

“We simply dug. That’s really all.” Rotorua’s grew red, probably due to Lloyd’s hard stare. “We made a shovel out of clams and dug around. Everyday. Without fail.”

“Wait.” Lloyd gaped, aghast. “You don’t mean you scoured around digging through the bottom of every ocean in the world?”

“Oh, my ancestors did that, but...”

“And now?”

“Through some research, we concluded that the land is near the Arctic Ocean. So we stopped trying to dig up all the oceans in the world.”

“Instead, you’re digging around the seabed here. Alone. Is that right?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd was at a loss for words. Now, he had the answer as to why the merman’s family had failed to find the land even after clinging to this mission their entire lives.

They’re like the epitome of inefficiency.

This entire sea, no, this Arctic Ocean alone was vast, and Rotorua was digging through its ground all by himself? In short, this was a matter of probability. Lloyd found himself clicking his tongue.

“Tsk. That’s why you haven’t found it,” Lloyd commented under his breath.

“What is that?”

“Nothing,” dismissed Lloyd, “Don’t mind what I said. Let’s go then.”

“Go?” said Rotorua, following suit. “But where?”

“To the last site you worked at.”

“Oh, does this mean you will join the excavation?”

“No. I’m not joining.”

“Then what is it?”

“I’ll finish the excavation in a blink of an eye.”

Lloyd smiled confidently as he pushed Rotorua to lead the way. He thought it was time to put an end to this inefficient, dead-end practice of shoveling the seabed. The reason was simple.

Surveying.

Bzzt! As soon as Lloyd arrived at the excavation site, he activated his surveying skill and meticulously examined the surrounding area, covering the entire seabed within his skill range. And just like that, he began to scan the topographical data of the ground up to 16 feet beneath him.

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Chapter 262: Mermaids Love Jjimjilbangs (1)

[Scanning will begin.]

Lloyd looked at his surroundings along with the message in front of his eyes. Until this moment, Javier's aura was the only source of light in the originally pitch-dark abyss. And it was the only thing that allowed Lloyd to discern what was around him. But when he activated his surveying skill, everything changed.

Crackle...! As though he had put on a pair of infrared night vision goggles, Lloyd's sight turned black and white, granting him a clear view of everything. The hydrothermal vent boiled near him, but apart from that, everything was quiet and calm. That was the view he had of the deep sea floor through his surveying skill. But Lloyd couldn't care less about the majestic scenery of the deep sea.

Like I can bother to admire the scenery of the deep sea when I have the Jewel of Truth to look for!

Lloyd's gaze traveled down to the bottom and got a glimpse of the ground 16 feet below him through his subterranean scanning skill, and he smiled confidently.

Why would I put in the effort to shovel when I have the subterranean scanning skill?

This optional skill allowed him to scan the ground that was 16 feet below him. Lloyd had found the skill to be beneficial for him in several instances throughout the past. With just a brief glance, he could see deep into the ground beneath him. It didn't require any effort from him to analyze the underground structure. Lloyd easily regarded it as the most useful skill in his possession and was confident that would be true for today as well.

I'll be seeing everything, including the seabed. And the Jewel of Truth buried in it will be the same.

Lloyd figured that the skill would cover every corner of the seabed. Sure, it could take one or two months to scan the whole area because of its vast size. But that was thousands of times better than going through the tedious process of hand shoveling. Lloyd was absolutely confident that this was the case. However, exactly a minute later, his conviction started to shake and tremble like the gaze of a person whose last train home left right in front of their eyes.

What's going on? What is this? Why's the mud... so thick?

His eyes darted around in alarm, carefully scanning the ground beneath him. But all he saw was a thick carpet of mud. A large amount of excessively thick mud and dirt. Otherwise, there were only some deep-sea eels wiggling in the mud. As soon as Lloyd saw the dancing eels through his surveying skill, he learned something right away.

Oh, crap. I'm screwed.

The mud was unexpectedly too thick. It was due to the static environment of the deep sea and the build-up of various organic matters and sediments that sprinkled down like snow from the surface.

The mud is thicker than the range of the Subterranean Scanning. Not just here but everywhere. It's all the same.

Lloyd clicked his tongue.

This is no use.

Lloyd had regarded Rotorua as a pathetic man for manually shoveling and grubbing around the sea for the Jewel of Truth. Lloyd regarded himself differently. After all, he had his surveying skill. The subterranean scanning skill would come into use and prove its worth. That was the source of his almighty confidence. But when he arrived and started surveying, he realized his mistake.

Agh... What should I do?

Lloyd was in a fix, indeed. Only the heavens knew where the Jewel of Truth was amid this boundless sea, and the situation was going downhill because the unexpectedly thick mud thicker rendered his skill useless. And now, Rotorua was pressuring him with a series of questions by his side.

“Now that you are here, how do you like it?” asked Rotorua expectantly. “Do you see the chance of finding the lot for the jewel?”

“No.” Lloyd frankly shook his head, suppressing his embarrassment. He wasn’t here to save his face or ego but to prevent the restoration of destiny from destroying everyone. He was here to find the Jewel of Truth.

Plus, I don’t have a lot of time on my hands. The Ending Spoiler told me I have, what, three years? Three years may seem long, but it’s actually short.

Truly, time was flying. It had been well over three years since he entered this world in *The Knight of Blood and Iron*. The restoration of destiny would begin before he even realized it. As he had that thought, he admitted his mistake without a fight.

“Now that I see it myself, this place is a lot larger than I expected. Plus, the mud is too thick,” pointed Lloyd with remorse.

“I knew it. I knew you would say that.”

“Yes,” agreed Lloyd, “But have you been digging through this thick mud to search for the jewel all by yourself until now?”

“There was no other way.” Rotorua smiled regretfully. “It’s not that my ancestors and I did not consider other methods. The most simple and efficient solution would be getting help from other merpeople. But that’s impossible for us to do regardless of what we know.”

“I see none of the other merpeople agreed to cooperate.” Lloyd understood right away.

“That is what happened.” There was more remorse on Rotorua’s face now. “You should be familiar with the atmosphere of this place after asking

around about the jewel. The merpeople here? None of them have any interest in it. They think of it as a distant legend of the past and impossible to find. What's more, the majority thinks it's a waste of time to go out and look for it."

"Is it because they don't feel any inconvenience without it currently?" asked Lloyd.

"Probably. After all, everyone believes swimming and working out is better than wasting their time searching for the Jewel of Truth."

"I see." Lloyd seconded Rotorua. Indisputably, the merpeople had no interest in the jewel.

Persuading them to join their search wasn't going to be plausible.

Tsk. But it's such a waste not to try. The merpeople are muscular nutjobs.

As long as they can be mobilized, they'll be able to shovel all day with their endless endurance.

Lloyd clicked his tongue in remorse. The more he let his imagination fly, the more regretful he became. It would be child's play to dig through and turn over a large portion of the sea floor if Lloyd could mobilize hundreds of merpeople with amazing physiques. With that, the chances of finding the jewel site would jump dramatically.

The chances of that happening are the same as winning a lottery.

It was a simple matter. Having one worker dig through the vast sea compared to having hundreds dig through it. Buying one lottery ticket compared to buying hundreds of them. The latter would promise a bigger chance of winning. Even though there wasn't any guarantee of winning, the chances would shoot up. On top of that, if he convinced Javier to join the effort? The jewel was sure to be found.

I really wish I could get these merpeople to help. Or should I just summon Draggy down here? No. Then they'll find out that I was behind the Draggy

incident.

Lloyd shook his head. He couldn’t call Draggy. Also, leaving all the digging to Javier was inefficient.

He could use his manablast on this whole place and remove the mud, but it wouldn’t be as powerful as it is on land. The water pressure is terrible down here.

The water pressure at this depth of water was unbelievable. It was beyond unbelievable. To give a dramatic comparison, imagine what would happen if a nuclear bomb were dropped in the Mariana Trench, the deepest part of the earth, and if the bomb was the RDS-200 Tsar Bomba, the most powerful nuclear bomb in history.

I saw it in a documentary before. Tsar Bomba? That was nothing to joke about. The blast wave from it circled the earth three times with the power of 50 megatons of TNT. Just its mushroom cloud reached 34 miles high into the air.

It wasn’t just that. The shockwave alone swept up and destroyed everything within 1,000 square kilometers. Its discharged energy was destructive enough to even dry up an entire lake. Without exaggeration, the diameter of the fireball’s crater reached over six miles long, and its height touched the boundaries of the troposphere and stratosphere.

But what would happen if I dropped it here? That would yield a very different outcome.

The fireball that was six miles long on land would only be six-tenth of a mile long down here due to the immense water pressure and turbulence that would crush it together. And eventually, the compressed fireball would diminish into a warm radioactive vapor that bubbled up to the surface.

it’d be like a big radioactive fart in the water. That’s just about it. The terrifying Tsar Bomba. It would be crushed into nothing under the water pressure.

That was how immense the water pressure was in the deep sea. As such, Javier's thousands of aura strands wouldn't have its usual capability to sweep across hundreds of yards at once.

Of course, he'll still be able to cover about a few dozen feet. Although that's better than just shoveling by hand, it's not quite enough. It's kind of a waste to completely rely on Javier when there's a whole pool of high-quality workers for this environment like the merpeople!

The merpeople were acclimated to the immense water pressure, and they could easily use their muscles here. That was the type of laborer Lloyd wanted. The chances of finding the jewel's site location would then increase significantly. But persuading them was one big hurdle.

Tsk. But still, there's got to be a way.

The merpeople were too valuable for him to give up on them so easily. From that moment on...

Work! Cerebrum! Think! Frontal lobe!

Lloyd desperately racked his brain. He painstakingly searched for a plan and agonized over finding a solution. Before he knew it, he began pacing back and forth, swimming along the water current close to him. After an unknown amount of time, he suddenly noticed a marginal change in his surroundings.

Hmm?

An unfamiliar scene unfolded in front of his eyes. Pillars shot up from the ground like a chimney, and a jet of water, hot and black, squirted out of them. Deep-sea organisms gathered around the dark water. Soon, Lloyd smelled a whiff of pungent sulfur. This was the place he glanced at from a distance with his skill.

Is that a black smoker hydrothermal vent?

Hydrothermal vents were sort of like a deep-sea hot spring, wherein the water that leaked underground shot back up after being heated with magma.

Tsk. I should avoid them.

It seemed that Lloyd mindlessly swam here while he was lost in thought. Frightened by the smoky smell and heat of the hydrogen sulfide, he hurriedly turned away. Just then...

Hold on. Wait a minute.

Ding! A brilliant idea hit Lloyd, so he stopped and quickly wheeled around to take a good look again at the vents.

“Um, Mister Rotorua?” asked Lloyd. “I have a question.” Lloyd then looked at Rotorua, who had followed the former with concern on his face. “Do joint diseases worsen with old age for merpeople like you?”

“Excuse me?”

“Joint problems,” Lloyd pointed, “Like arthralgia, where your joints remain sore year-round.”

“Well, somewhat... They do,” Rotorua mumbled and nodded. “As you have seen so far, we merpeople have excellent muscles. But because they are so huge, our joints are strained oftentimes. In particular, as this kind of stress accumulates over the years, quite a number of us suffer from joint pain.”

“Is that so? I knew it.”

The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose a little. His mind flew back to the time he went around asking merpeople about the Jewel of Truth. Particularly, he recalled the granny mermaid who was exceedingly bothered by Lloyd as if he were a cult member.

That granny mermaid told me that I shouldn’t be pestering her when she’s already going nuts from her sore joints.

Lloyd remembered the way she constantly tapped her shoulders and waist like someone with severe joint pain. When Lloyd thought about it more, the granny wasn't the only one.

The senile and mid-aged mermen were like that too. Out of the countless merpeople that I've stopped, those past puberty all looked like they were sore and in pain somewhere.

Much like sedentary, white-collared office workers and taxi or bus drivers at the wheel. No, more like a retired athlete who strained their body from overtraining, they all habitually massaged and rubbed their aching joints.

Lloyd could speculate and assume that the merpeople's excessive volume of muscle was constantly putting stress on their joints, which was naturally becoming a source of pain for them with age.

My speculation was right. In that case, I have a chance.

Lloyd sensed it. And he followed his intuition to put together everything he knew to form a broader perspective - the merpeople suffering from chronic joint pain, the hydrothermal vent, the countless pieces of information he gathered, and other seemingly irrelevant situations or elements. Lloyd jumbled, assembled, and compounded all everything until they materialized into one business idea. This business would be used for his goal, that is, mobilizing countless merpeople to discover the site of the Jewel of the Truth. Ultimately, it would lead Lloyd to find a way to stop the restoration of destiny.

"I think it'll be a big hit if I open a *jjimjilbang* here," Lloyd said at last.

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Chapter 263: Mermaids Love Jjimjilbangs (2)

Jjimjilbang. A popular location that was loved by most Korean people. A space where they could enjoy a tender boiled egg with a sip of ice cold sikhye, a sweet rice beverage, washing away all their prolonged stress and exhaustion. Lloyd, too, had been to a jjimjilbang in South Korea. Just once.

It was around the time I was working nonstop on construction sites.

There was a period when he was blessed with an endless amount of work. He made daily visits to construction sites without taking a single break between them. His daily wages piled high in his bank account, and he was elated. But in return, it took a serious toll on his body.

I didn't have any time to relax and unwind. Even after finishing my work at construction sites, I had to head home and study.

Though he was on leave due to his next semester's tuition fees and was free from the stress of schoolwork, he couldn't sit back and idle away. He had a goal to graduate, get a license, and land a decent job. Then liberate himself from the sickening, heavy financial shackles weighing down on him. And finally, start an ordinary family and live a normal life without any large troubles or worries. That was the ultimate goal he had back in South Korea.

To others, it was an ordinary and modest goal, but to him, it wasn't. He was desperate and despaired over his goal, so he barely rested to that end. He had at least seven nose bleeds every week. Not only that, his nutrition was also quite poor, having relied only on rice, noodle, and kimchi provided by his room rental for free. And thus, it went without saying that his face was yellow as if he had serious jaundice.

And one day, when fatigue was cruelly weighing him down, right before he crawled back home after one of his construction jobs, Lloyd's coworker called him.

"Suho, do you want to go to a jjimjilbang after work if you have no other plans?"

But, of course, Lloyd shook his head and turned down the offer. It was the only choice he had. He was penniless. And going to a jjimjilbang? That was an unimaginable luxury. Thinking that he might as well spend the money on noodles and a few more canned tunas instead, he awkwardly smiled and said he was busy rather than saying he was broke. He was too embarrassed to say the truth. He told his friend to go alone and refused. But his friend said...

“Hey, you’re going to get sick if you keep living like this. I’m paying. We’re going, you bastard.”

Lloyd jumped at the chance. Free! How nice! And when he arrived and saw the place for the first time, his jaw dropped. A red clay room. A diamond seawater room. And there were many other rooms with all sorts of different themes. The whole facility was beyond what Lloyd had expected. And there were the boiled eggs! The savory flavor was more delicious than he could have ever imagined. Lloyd wondered if those eggs were the same as the ones he had always eaten before. And then what about the iced sikhye he drank with the eggs? His eyes welled with tears of happiness as he took his first sweet sip. Having always drank nothing but lukewarm tap water, which only the heavens knew when it was last cleaned, sikhye tasted like nectar blessed by the gods.

Ah, those were good times.

And as he left the jjimjilbang, he resolved to himself that he would frequent this place once every week when he got a job and lived a decent, humane life. Lloyd had made a firm resolve in his heart. But unfortunately, he wasn’t able to keep this promise.

Getting a job? Ha. I was brought here before I could get one.

Lloyd finished off his trip down memory lane with a bitter smile. And he looked beside him. People he newly met. There was Javier, who was lifting his brow like someone out of a beautiful painting. And Rotorua, looking up at Lloyd with his head tilted to the side. The two of them were eyeing him with curiosity in their eyes. Lloyd smiled.

Oh, they must have never heard of a jjimjilbang.

Come to think of it, that was the case. Lloyd cleared his throat.

“Hmm. Ehem. You must have never heard of it until today, right?” asked Lloyd.

“You are correct,” affirmed Rotorua grimly. “Um... What is it about the place that makes you so certain it’ll be a success here? And what does it have anything to do with unearthing the jewel’s site location?”

“Yes.” Lloyd brought his hands together. “To simply answer your two questions, I want to give you a yes.”

“What on earth is a jjimjilbang?”

Lloyd sensed impatience in Rotorua’s voice. “It is a place where you heat your body with hot water or steam.”

“Heat my body?” Rotorua was almost rooted to the spot at the suggestion.

“Oh, of course, but not like how we heat up food.” Lloyd chuckled before he went on with his explanation. “I mean, it’s where you warm up your body but not until you get burned. The heat is supposed to relax your muscles and release tension.”

“Hmm,” mused Rotorua, “I know of something similar to a jjimjilbang. It is not that we merpeople do not enjoy hot massages.”

“Really? That is new.” Lloyd was glad that the concept was familiar.

“Indeed. Though it is illegal.”

“What do you mean illegal?” asked Lloyd, interested.

“Exactly what I mean,” replied Rotorua, “It seems as though you thought of this jjimjilbang after looking at the hydrothermal vent, but actually, we merpeople enjoy secretly getting a massage in these sorts of locations.”

“Secretly?”

“Yes, since it is dangerous.”

“Dangerous, you say...”

“The water over there is too hot,” pointed out Rotorua. “It can be an adequate source of heat at a reasonable distance and good position. However, that is hard to determine.”

Lloyd nodded. “I see what you mean.”

“Right? But the bigger problem is that the water is not very clear.”

“Are you talking about the toxic substance?”

“Toxic substance, you say. That’s probably right. If you drink the water in the area by accident, you start to become dazed, struggle to breathe, and lose consciousness in an instant. So, it is very dangerous.”

“Hmm... I see. It would be extremely dangerous for you to be floating around unconscious with extremely hot water gushing out beside you.”

“Yes. It makes it more than likely for you to get a severe burn. If you are unlucky, you might die. So, that is why it is forbidden to warm yourself at the hydrothermal vent.” Rotorua’s eyes, which were fixed on Lloyd, were filled with doubt. “But do you plan on constructing a facility for that? The queen will not allow it. No, even if she does, it will not be easy to have the merpeople overcome their fear and reluctance. Have you thought about that?”

“Yes, I did.” Lloyd nodded, thinking that it was a simple matter. “That is a good point. But all I need to do is provide an adequate amount of heat control and block the toxic substance from entering the jjimjilbang facility. These two things will be the main focus of this construction project.”

“So, is there a way for us to manage this?”

“Of course,” Lloyd replied confidently. He was certain of it.

Of course. This isn't something I'd joke about or half-ass.

There were no second chances. It was essential to conserve time and energy in the process of discovering the jewel's site location, constructing the jewel with the blueprint, and finally finding a method to stop the restoration of destiny. Only the heavens knew how much more time and effort Lloyd would have to pour in to execute the method he found. Considering this point, he couldn't carelessly handle any of the tasks or processes that needed to be completed.

Do I think the merpeople will welcome my jjimjilbang with open arms and love when I build the facility? I might as well give up on this project with such naive expectations.

Lloyd had carefully thought through his entire plan. The safety measures in the jjimjilbang. The elements that would charm the merpeople, draw them in, and make them fall in love with it. And how he'd use that love to his advantage to achieve his ultimate goal of forcing a work contract onto the merpeople. In no uncertain terms, Lloyd had a plan.

"So," continued Lloyd, "Please lead me."

"Lead you? To where?" Rotorua looked at Lloyd.

"Is there a cave or something like that nearby?" Lloyd asked without answering the question.

"There is."

"How far is it from here?"

"Hmm, around a distance of five Gigatitans."

"Five Gigatitans..." pondered Lloyd, "That would be about 400 yards away."

"That should be about it from your standard measurement. Do you want me to take you there?"

“Yes.”

“...”

Rotorua stared at Lloyd. He thought that this human was a bit unique. No, weird would be a better word to describe him. At first, he had scoured the city, claiming to search for the Jewel of Truth. Eventually, the man excitedly met with him for that purpose. Then he seemed to become suspicious of him. When his suspicions were resolved, Lloyd declared he’d build a jjimjilbang or whatever it was, as if that would solve everything. Furthermore…

Plus, there is the silver-haired man beside him. He has an interesting attitude as well.

Rotorua’s gaze then moved to Javier, whom he pegged to be working for this human named Lloyd. The man wasn’t stopping his master’s actions or asking any questions either. He continued maintaining his stoic composure even after hearing Lloyd’s ridiculous suggestion to build a jjimjilbang. It was as if he had complete trust that everything would work out just by following Lloyd’s plan.

Hmm.

Rotorua gulped. Something didn’t sit right with him, and the thought that these two guys were swindlers crossed his mind. The rumors had it that land humans were sly and cunning creatures who were willing to commit even the most heinous crimes for gold or money.

But...

Rotorua shook his head. It was his first time meeting anyone who was looking for the Jewel of Truth. Moreover, at the same time, he was slightly getting tired of this whole expedition.

I was stuck.

He had devoted over 20 years to this job but found no success. The fear of spending his life meaninglessly digging dirt at the bottom of the sea until he died of old age just like many of his ancestors, including his grandfather and father, suffocated Rotorua at times. He wondered if he'd also eventually pass down the mission of finding the jewel to his son before passing away.

I don't want that.

He was scared and didn't want to lead such a futile life. But if he continued as he was now, that seemed to be his inevitable future. However, he encountered an unexpected source of help today.

I might not find an opportunity like this again.

An explorer looking for the Jewel of Truth other than him. Rotorua decided to put his hopes on this human. Resolved, he nodded at Lloyd and said, "Good. I will take you to the cave. Follow me."

Rotorua led the way. The cave was not very far from where they were.

"Oh." Lloyd's eyes shone as he arrived and admired the cave entrance.

This is nice.

It was much better than what he expected. The entrance was vast, about 22 feet wide and 32 feet high.

What about the inside?

Lloyd entered the cave with the help of Javier's aura to light up the place. The inside turned out to be better.

Wow. This looks like a karaoke room!

The cave stretched 820 feet long. The main corridor at the center extended in an almost straight line from the entrance to the exit, with small and large rooms attached on all sides. The smallest one was about the size of a college dorm. The biggest one was close to the size of a university auditorium.

This is amazing. It's perfect. Just perfect.

Lloyd's heart pounded as he surveyed the inside as the whole space was unbelievably perfect for actualizing his jjimjilbang blueprint.

Looking at what's here, I can say that a chunk of the construction has already been completed. Foundation work? There's hardly much left to do. I'll just smooth out some rough edges, divide the sauna rooms according to their themes, place down pipes for the hydrothermal vents, add some convenience facilities, and et voila!

This construction didn't require much effort from him. From that moment on, Lloyd hit the ground running, going in and out of the cave for four days straight and surveying the inside structure. He simultaneously engrossed himself in surveying the entire place, concentrating on the areas and points that required repairs, reinforcements, and the exit and entrance channel for the hydrothermal vent. Lloyd thought over, planned, and designed every element of the construction. Meanwhile, he excitedly made sure Javier was put to work as well.

"Hey, Javier," called Lloyd.

"What work do you plan on giving me now, Young Master?" grumbled Javier curtly.

"Ha!" puffed Lloyd. "Can you already tell what I want just from hearing your name?"

"You slaved me around too many times." Javier chuckled. "By this time, I cannot tell whether I am your personal guard knight or a practical piece of construction equipment."

"Yeah? You can't tell yet, huh?" quipped Lloyd as he wiggled his brows.

"You couldn't be..." Javier became goggle-eyed. A look of disbelief came over him.

“You are a knight. Have some pride,” said Lloyd as he smiled. “How could I so shamelessly think of you as a piece of construction equipment?”

“Do you... mean it?” said Javier, relaxing his muscles a little.

“Of course I do. You are a knight. Our fiefdom’s most honorable knight, Sir Javier Asrahan.”

“Hmm,” reflected Javier and squinted his eyes.

“What? What? What is it? Why are you glaring like that when I’m being nice.”

“I am wondering whether you are up to something.”

“Up to something?” blurted Lloyd, offended. “I’m not up to anything.”

“Do you really mean it?”

“Of course. Sir Asrahan, what’s wrong? Do you feel embarrassed about being properly treated as a knight? Is that it?”

“That is not it.”

“It’s not, right?”

“No.”

“Then time to get to work.” Lloyd then put his arm around Javier’s shoulders. “Do you remember the hydrothermal vents from earlier? Near them, there should be some long, thin shells that look like bamboo.”

Javier turned and shot Lloyd an I-knew-it look.

“Those are called giant tube worms. Collect as many of their outer shells as you can for me. I just need the ones that are thicker than your thighs. Also, make sure to leave out any of them that are cracked or chipped,” instructed Lloyd.

"..."

Seeing that Javier wasn't reacting to him, Lloyd asked, "By chance, do you not want to do this job, Sir Asrahan?"

Finally, Javier clicked his tongue, lashing out inwardly at Lloyd for sweet-talking him into being treated as a piece of construction equipment.

Haah... You are not even the real Lloyd.

Regretfully licking his bitter lips, he turned, returned to the hydrothermal vent, and buckled down to collect the shells. But not without rage.

While Javier was busy with his task, Lloyd preoccupied himself with constructing the jjimjilbang. For this project, he utilized the water pipe construction method. Since the facility was built in the deep sea, Lloyd employed all the knowledge he had to make sure there wouldn't be any malfunctions. With that resolve, he finished everything from determining the pipe thickness, installing the pipe conduit, employing the water pipe branching method, calculating the area of exposure, and performing the installation method. The veins in his eyes popped out as Lloyd stared at the design blueprint. Each day, Javier became faster and more adept at collecting the giant tube worms' shells. Five days later. And at last.

Great.

Lloyd gazed at the perfected design blueprint with a glow of satisfaction. At last, the moment to lure the merpeople into a labor contract negotiation using an incredible, first-ever construction of a seabed jjimjilbang was nearing.

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Chapter 264: Mermaids Love Jjimjilbangs (3)

And thus, the seabed jjimjilbang construction began.

“So,” said Lloyd, “From now on, bring the giant tube worms’ secretions.”

“The worms’ secretions?” Javier looked at Lloyd with disgust all over his face.

“Yeah.”

“How much should I bring?”

“As much as you can. Keep it coming until I tell you to stop,” chuckled Lloyd as he held out a conch shell that was incomparably larger than average. It was large enough to fit a human into it.

Taking the conch from Lloyd, Javier sighed, “I see.” He wasn’t entirely happy about it. But he was left with no choice. After all, every single thing the fake Lloyd did ended up being the correct choice, and Javier knew that would probably be the case this time too.

He always does something strange. I cannot wrap my head around his ridiculous orders or bizarre actions. But sometime later, his orders and actions are always revealed to be backed by clear reason and purpose.

That was how Lloyd had been saving the Frontera family up until today. Javier presumed it’d be the same this time as well.

It is beyond me how building a jjimjilbang facility deep down in this water is relevant to stopping the restoration of destiny, but I should just follow his orders. I’ll trust him.

Recalling his previous observations of fake Lloyd until this moment, Javier obediently moved forward and approached the boiling hydrothermal vents.

Shhhh! When he approached the hundreds of worms, they reacted by secreting sticky liquid. Javier immediately held up his conch and filled it up just in time.

This liquid is sticky. I suppose they usually use it to build their houses. It is like glue.

At last, Javier understood, though vaguely, why Lloyd instructed him to collect the giant tube worms' secretions. It was to be used in place of cement. From then onward, Javier filled the conch up and moved it to the construction site, where Lloyd mixed it up with mud. He then slathered the mixture onto the floor, walls, and ceiling of the cave.

Tralalala. Lalala.

Lloyd worked on his giant tube worm cement as he hummed, closely resembling a construction plasterer as he did. And much like one, Lloyd adeptly covered almost the entire cave with cement. Even though it was an immense amount of work for one person, Lloyd's stamina was well beyond that of an average person.

Huff! Hufff! Huffff! His manaheart was already at the level of a mid-level sword expert, and on top of that, he was equipped with a triple circle. As a result, he was a tireless ball of energy that was able to work nonstop. All the while, he didn't forget to secure and lay the pipes that would draw up the hot water from the hydrothermal vents.

"Hey," called Lloyd, "This is enough worm secretion. It's time for something else."

"Should I bring the worms' shells now?" asked Javier.

"Oh! I don't even need to ask anymore."

"I hold a bounty of experiences with you, Master Lloyd." Javier sighed, almost in a grumbling manner. "Survey. Design. Basic construction. Clear the ground, set up the structure, and pour cement. Finish that up. If pipes

are necessary, lay them down when it’s around our current time. I roughly know the order of how construction sites are operated now.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes.”

“Wow, good for you,” Lloyd said without bothering to hide his sarcasm. “I’m jealous. You must be happy about it. Congratulations, sincerely.”

Javier gritted his teeth, trying to make sense of how he had wound up here in the seabed for a construction project. An intense wave of dismay and self-hatred crept up from the bottom of his soul. Despite that, however, he didn’t idle and slack off. He dutifully transferred the shells he collected in advance and tidied them up with Lloyd. He cut and refined them into their necessary size, glued them together with cement, and connected them to five hydrothermal vent chimneys.

“Hey! Push!”!

Crack! Lloyd and Javier moved in sync, pushing the pipes while maintaining distance from the vent to avoid getting burned. The pipes fit perfectly and covered the hydrothermal vents.

Brrr! Brrr! The 752 ℉, highly acidic hydrogen sulfide, lead, and iron-enriched seawater traveled into the pipes, and Lloyd activated his survey skill right away.

[Scanning will begin.]

Bzzt! His eyes meticulously surveyed the pipes to ensure they were absolutely free from any leakage of hot water or toxic substance. His eyes shined like they did when he was picking out a cut of Australian sirloin steak on his payday. A moment later, Lloyd sighed in relief.

Great. There aren’t any leaks.

There were no leaks from the hydrothermal vent, the inner area of the jjimjilbang, and even all the way to the cave exit. There wasn't a single leak. The construction was a complete success. From then on, Lloyd cracked down and devoted himself to the construction with greater zeal, starting with laying down the pipes. Most of the pipes received an additional layer of cement to avoid unintentionally having any heat escape from somewhere. Lloyd made sure that the heat would only flow to the rooms inside the facility. With this, a clear change had been made.

Oh! It's gotten hotter.

The temperature inside spiked dramatically. Once that was taken care of, Lloyd moved on to refine and touch the inside of the cave, first building a door out of gigantic clam and crab shells. And then he divided the whole place into rooms with varying themes: a traditional red clay room, a seaweed-filled seawater room, an emerald room filled with glowing plankton glass marvels, a tropical beach room covered in the white sand, a Himalayan glacier room, a spin-dryer room, and an extreme bungee-jump room. Lloyd took extra care to ensure that the merpeople would not get bored. And lastly, he constructed a resting area that was as big as an auditorium, which was set to be the main facility of the jjimjilbang.

So, this would be the place for merpeople to laze around and read comics as they eat boiled eggs.

After 21 days, the construction was finally complete. It was hardly an exaggeration to say it had been done at the speed of lightning.

Haah. What a relief. I was able to finish quickly because there was a cave nearby. I got lucky.

And the inside of the cave was equally impressive. It almost seemed like a gift from mother nature to build a jjimjilbang down here. Lloyd was happy to skip the foundation work that usually took up the most amount of time and energy during construction. As a result, he was able to completely focus on installing and laying down the hydrothermal vents as well as the interior construction work.

Now, it’s time to welcome customers.

Now that the jjimjilbang was completed, it was time to bring the merpeople to the place. This job was entrusted to Rotorua.

“What now? When are the merpeople who promised to be here coming?” asked Lloyd.

“Oh, the thing is...” The night the jjimjilbang construction was finished, Rotorua came to Lloyd with a troubled look on his face. “Um... The thing is, I did receive a promise from some of my acquaintances a few days ago that they will be here as soon as this place opens. They promised, really...”

“But what?” blurted Lloyd, his voice dripping with alarm. “Wait...”

Rotorua looked down.

“They said they will come next time.” Lloyd instantly realized what was going on.

“I am sorry. I have nothing to say for myself.” Rotorua’s shoulders drooped.

Lloyd clicked his tongue.

Tsk, tsk. I had a bad feeling about this, and I was right.

Without a doubt, Rotorua was an outsider who didn’t have many friends. So, Lloyd didn’t hold high expectations of him. Even when Rotorua beamed proudly at Lloyd and boasted to the latter that his acquaintances were coming, Lloyd told himself, “Let’s see.” And sure enough, he was right.

Them saying that they’ll come the next time they can mean they will not come at all. It’s the same as the empty promises people make in Korea to grab a meal with someone soon.

However, Lloyd wasn’t disappointed. He instead tapped Rotorua’s shoulders.

“Don’t worry,” Lloyd comforted. “Do not be too discouraged. I have another plan in mind.”

“Um,” replied Rotorua as he lifted his head and looked at Lloyd. “Did you prepare for this to happen in advance?”

“I sure did.” Lloyd’s voice seemed to indicate that it was only obvious. “The merpeople are not familiar with the concept of a jjimjilbang. This should be their first encounter with one. And not only that, it was constructed by Javier and me, people from the surface. So-”

“You expected that the merpeople would not regard it so positively,” Rotorua broke in.

“Yes,” said Lloyd, “I have been thinking that the only way to gain traction would be to stimulate their curiosity and excitement.”

“Hmm... So, what plan do you have in mind?”

“It’s this one. Hold on.” Lloyd lifted his finger and head to the counter, where he took out two giant lumps. Rotorua had to look closely to make out what they were.

“Is that... the shell of the gigantic lobster and crab?” observed Rotorua.

“Yes, that is right.” Lloyd grinned. “Javier and I will be promoting the jjimjilbang wearing this.”

Javier, who had been listening to the conversation without saying anything, flinched. He then looked at Lloyd as if he was a madman. Lloyd smiled more shamelessly.

“What? What? What is it?”

“...”

“Don’t insult me with your gaze. Speak,” challenged Lloyd.

“Can I insult you with my mouth?” Javier finally asked.

“What’s wrong?” Lloyd picked up the giant, human-sized crab shell. “Is it because I’m going to make you wear this?”

A look of anger appeared on Javier’s face. “I am not a clown, Master Lloyd.”

“Yeah,” acknowledged Lloyd, “I know. You’re a knight.”

“I am. I am a knight as you said. I am glad that you are aware of this fact. So why do you suggest that I, a knight, wear such an unsightly thing?” asked Javier indignantly.

“For the sake of the family you are loyal to?”

Javier frowned in confusion.

“Wear this, and everything will be solved,” promised Lloyd. “The Frontera family will further prosper and even be able to avoid danger. You know, it’s not like we’re doing this for me. I don’t want to do this either.”

Javier merely stared at Lloyd, trying to comprehend where he was getting at.

“But do you know what will happen if you refuse? Oh! That was the moment.” Lloyd suddenly started to talk theatrically, even making hand gestures. “No one knew that this moment marked the beginning of the Frontera family’s downfall. But the circle of tragedy had been turning long before then... You will be hearing a history teacher saying these words 200 years from today.”

“That is just outrageous-”

“All because Sir Asrahan did not cooperate,” Lloyd chimed in, this time with more effect. “He failed to attract the merpeople. The jjimjilbang went under. The jewel couldn’t be found. The family fell. Society collapsed. The villagers plunged into misery.”

“...”

“One boy in the miserable fiefdom was forced to starve all day. His puppy starved together with him. The two tightly embraced each other, only relying on each other’s body heat to get through the cold night. But not a single person came to their aid. And just like that, the boy and the dog slowly but surely drew in their final breaths of air. And right before he died, a drop of tear welled up under his eyes. He whispered to himself, his last whisper sad. Oh, oh... Only if Sir Asrahan had put on the gigantic crab shell...”

“...”

“Hearing those last words, the dog whimpered and licked the boy’s cheeks. But the boy didn’t move. That is when the dog realized that the time had come for him to follow the boy. So, the dog-”

“I will wear it,” Javier huffed, shaking his head.

“All right, good thinking. My little puppy.”

Javier’s face darkened.

“Oops, I made a mistake because you interrupted me in the middle of the story. Ehem. Good thinking, Javier.”

Javier clamped his mouth shut, and Lloyd happily handed over the shell as if he had been waiting for this moment. Javier could not hate the latter enough. But at the same time, he had to admit it.

Ha. It is beyond me what’s going on, but...

It was undeniably true that the fake Lloyd was doing all of this to save the family. As such, actively helping this eccentric madman was the right thing to do, even if his ways were unconventional and absurd. If not, the lord was set to pass away in three years’ time.

“...”

At last, Javier threw away his pride and decided to wear the thing. He put on the shell and inserted his hands into its pincers, which covered half of his

torso except for his legs. Meanwhile, Lloyd also threw on a giant lobster shell and went further by wearing a sign he had prepared in advance. The sign had “Grand Opening Event! Free Jjimjilbang Entrance!” written in a large font.

“All right, let’s go,” hurried Lloyd at Javier with his pincers.

“...”

“What are you doing? Come, hurry up and follow me.”

“...”

Lloyd glanced behind his shoulder as he waddled in his lobster costume. Javier, who was behind him, had to desperately fight against his desire to resign on the spot.

Haah. Patience. This is all for the lord and his family.

With that resolution in mind, he waddled over to Lloyd and entered the merpeople’s city. And when they settled in the most crowded area in the egg, Javier heard Lloyd’s enthusiastic shouting to bring in customers.

“Everyone!” bawled Lloyd. “This is a rare opportunity! To celebrate the first-ever jjimjilbang in the Mermaid Kingdom! It’s a completely free event! Don’t you want to safely relax your muscles without having the scent of sulfur assaulting your nose? Don’t your aching joints bother you?! Come over and enjoy yourselves, my dearest customers!” Lloyd clapped and bawled in excitement.

“...”

Javier suddenly felt a shaft of reverence toward Lloyd for being able to scream those words without shame. At the same time, he thought to himself...

I don’t think I’ll be as effective.

Indeed, Javier was right. The ridiculous costume. Lloyd's exaggerated shouts. Sure, they were able to make the merpeople pause their swimming. There was a crowd gathering around them in curiosity. But that was all there was to it.

They are laughing at us.

They were laughing at Lloyd because they were amused by his clownish manners. They were simply giving momentary attention to them as if they were looking at a circus attraction. Not a single merperson in the crowd seemed interested in the jjimjilbang.

What on earth was he thinking...?

No matter how Javier looked at it, this was a hopeless affair. A desperate, unsightly effort. Javier licked his lips regretfully and wondered if he should stop fake Lloyd, so he could at least be saved from the blatant mockery. The moment he had that thought, Lloyd came to Javier's side.

"Plus, if you all come to my jjimjilbang!" Lloyd dramatically shouted and held out his hands and put them on Javier's shoulders. Then he gave a hard tug downward. "You can admire this face as you keep enjoying your treatments!"

Crack! As soon as Lloyd pressed down on Javier's costume, Javier's head broke out of the shell like a pimple popping out of someone's skin. And with that, his face was revealed.

"...!"

And his face had a phenomenal effect on the crowd.

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Chapter 265: Mermaids Love Jjimjilbangs (4)

You may run away from Hell, but the real Hell awaits you there. Lloyd wasn't the type to believe those kinds of sayings. But that changed when he tried out another part-time job after becoming tired of doing grueling construction work under the hot sun.

That happened on the first day I was out for the mascot costume job!

It was a temp job at a newly opened fried chicken restaurant. Lloyd was asked to distribute ad flyers in a chicken mascot costume. It was during one of the hottest days of the summer when he got a taste of Hell.

I really thought I was going to die.

At first, Lloyd rejoiced. He was away from the typical harsh, grimy construction sites and trying out something else. But his joy and excitement vanished one minute into the job. Under the sun during the hottest days of the summer, he was tasked to go around the streets in a fluffy chicken costume and give out leaflets, all while putting on a charming act. That day, he learned that humans could sweat as much as he did then and the neighborhood kids darting at him in cackles and kicking him were devils. On top of everything, he also learned the cold, hard truth that the world loved nothing more than a handsome face.

Was it Yeongjin? Whew. The name is stuck in my head.

Yeongjin was his coworker at the job. Lloyd met him for the first time that day. But the name could not be erased from his head because of a notably awful incident that occurred on this particular date.

Yeongjin suggested we get a can of soda before we collapse to the ground from heat exhaustion.

Yeongjin said it'd be his treat. Having wanted to rest as well, Lloyd hurried to the convenience store and bought some sports drinks. They sat under a

parasol in front of the store to hydrate themselves. When they both removed their costume head, chaos broke loose.

When Yeongjin threw off the costume head, it revealed his gorgeous face... And he brushed his sweat-soaked hair as he chugged his canned drink and wiped the sweat on his pale cheek... Then under his sharp jawline, his Adam's apple bobbed... Which caused a few young female students passing by to scream in shock.

That day, the chicken restaurant raked in money. The first day of business was a slam dunk. What was more, Yeongjin went viral on social media as the "Hongdae Chicken Mascot Man." The last time Lloyd heard, Yeongjin was scouted into some sort of talent agency.

"..."

Handsome guys were so disgustingly unfair. They had it so easy for everything. Lloyd shook his head and shoved the memory deep into his brain before looking up. The lessons Lloyd learned that day were being successfully applied here. As the shell crushed under the pressure of Lloyd's hands and revealed Javier's face, the latter's gorgeousness allured everyone, who screamed in shock.

After all, it only took his face to get permission to enter this kingdom.

Javier was handsome. That was a sufficiently proven fact. Lloyd purposefully set up a scene with some slight nudging. The status quo was poles apart from the days when Lloyd asked the merpeople around about the jewel. Back then, Javier had his face cast down, never looking up even once due to embarrassment, and the merpeople were busy swimming off from Lloyd's unending questions. As such, most of the merpeople didn't get a good look at Javier's face. However, that wasn't the case today. His face was plainly revealed to every merperson gathered around them after Lloyd cracked the shell he was wearing.

The result? Victory. A couple of the merpeople drawn by Javier's face became their first jjimjilbang customers. They entered in confusion at first, looking around, but all came out happy and relaxed. And then they started

to spread the news about the facility to the others, how there was this place called a jjimjilbang, how it was the perfect place to relax your muscles and heal your joint pain. And all for free! It was safe even! The stories of the facility traveled surprisingly fast with great detail throughout the city. And six days after the jjimjilbang's opening...

Clamor! Clamor! Everywhere Lloyd looked, the entire jjimjilbang was packed with merpeople. Some were walking as their silky hair danced sideways, and some were relaxing their defined muscles. Some were moving their fins happily, and some were sleeping. All of them were having a fantastic time in their own way. However, that wasn't all.

"Come on! I was first in the line!"

"Liar, liar, pants on fire! I have been standing in line since last night!"

There were constant quarrels outside the jjimjilbang as Lloyd started to limit entry due to overcapacity after too many merpeople came rushing in at once. As such, the merpeople outside often cut in line and fought as they waited to get in.

This is nothing less than incredible.

The corners of his lips rose in contentment. His plan to mobilize the merpeople through the jjimjilbang was a stellar success. So, now...

Time to move on to the next stage.

Lloyd sensed that the time was now. Since he had given the merpeople the heavenly taste of the jjimjilbang, it was time to move on to his next step. That night, Lloyd set up a big sign at the entrance of the jjimjilbang.

***

The following morning rolled around.

"Oh my? What is this?" A granny mermaid rubbed her senile eyes in disbelief. She tilted her muscular neck and stared hard at the sign in front of the jjimjilbang entrance. And the words in it gutted her deeply.

[Jjimjilbang Promotional Event Is Now Over]

[From today, the jjimjilbang will no longer be free. For more information, please read below. Thank you.]

What is happening now?

The granny mermaid clenched her fists reflexively. No more free entrances? A sort of payment was required to use the jjimjilbang, perhaps? There was now a price to treat her entire body with warm water and forget about her aching joints?

What is the payment, then?

The granny mermaid had come here with the resolution to further enjoy the sauna rooms than the day before and treat herself the entire day until night came. As such, the granny mermaid was flustered, to say the least. In one part, she also felt nervous. Calming her nerves, she looked somewhere else.

Look below for more information?

She looked down and found a flat rock that held several rolls of refined seaweed. She picked one up and opened it to find tiny words written on it.

“Jjimjilbang Sign-up Form?” The wrinkles on her forehead deepened. Her eyes quickly moved.

[Seabed Cave Jjimjilbang Sign-up Form]

[This form serves the purpose of ensuring the best and smoothest experience possible for our customers. Please carefully read the terms and conditions before filling out the form.]

Terms and conditions?

The granny mermaid felt an inexplicable sense of anxiety creeping up inside her. Her eyes moved to the terms and conditions.

[Jjimjilbang Membership Terms and Conditions]

(1) Seabed Cave Jjimjilbang (“Jjimjilbang”) is strictly membership-based. Those who are not members will be restricted from entering and patronizing the facility.

(2) The maximum hours the members can patronize the facility is 12 hours every day.

(3) All members must pay a small fee to patronize the jjimjilbang. The small fee will not come in monetary or material form. It shall be in the form of labor in the areas designated by the owner of the jjimjilbang, Lloyd Frontera.

Shut up! Labor? I have to work for Lloyd Frontera and go wherever that land human wants me to! For what? To use the facility?

Fright filled her eyes. At the same time, a crippling sense of anger came over her.

Is this human a madman or what? What does he think about us merpeople?

She was upset. She wouldn’t feel this way if Lloyd had asked for precious shells or pearls. But instead, he was demanding the merpeople to work for him.

What an impertinent human!

She shook her head, affirming her perception of humans once again. Pesky and nosy. Environment destroyers. Her angry eyes quickly moved to continue and read the rest.

(4) The number of labor hours required to use the jjimjilbang will be half of an individual's time spent inside the facility. (For example, if you stayed six hours, you should work three hours.)

(5) Members must labor within two days (48 hours) of using the jjimjilbang. If the members fail to comply within the time frame, they will face one of three restrictions in using the facility.

What? Restrictions in using the facility?

She clicked her tongue. The labor compensation part was already ludicrous enough, and now what? Members will be banned from using the jjimjilbang if they don’t pay up within 48 hours? Nothing was more tyrannical than this.

Fine. I’ll see what restrictions you have set forth.

A glint of righteous anger appeared in her eyes.

(6) Usage restrictions in the event of failure to pay.

① One default: Ban from the jjimjilbang for ten days.

② Two defaults: Ban from the jjimjilbang for 30 days.

③ Three defaults: Loss of membership and the right to sign up again. A permanent ban from the jjimjilbang.

(7) First-come, first-served signup event: The first 100 members to sign up will receive a complimentary 60 hours on us.

The granny mermaid was at a loss for words. So, in short, to sum up the terms and conditions...

I have to work to use the jjimjilbang, and I’ll get three warnings if I don’t. After three strikes, it’s a permanent ban.

She scoffed dryly. The more she thought about it, the more speechless she became. What kind of a human would do such a thing? Worm-like veins in her curved upper torso popped in anger.

“Like hell I would! What a filthy antic! I won’t use it then.”

Rip! The seaweed scroll paper was torn into shreds in her hands, and she turned away. Her pecs bulged out in anger. This reaction was similar to every person that came after her.

“Sure, I love relaxing in a hot sauna... But enough to work for a human?”

“Oh, come on! This clearly shows how he looks down on us merpeople!”

“I know, right? Even though one of them is drop-dead gorgeous and the sauna is very relaxing and comfortable, this is too much. He’s asking for our labor as payment, not pearls? What does he think of us? Does he see us as cheap labor for him to exploit?”

“Nope. I’ll just stop going to his sauna.”

“Me neither. We’ve been fine all along without this jjimjilbang.”

“Yes, indeed. It was never part of our lifestyle anyway. We can live without it just fine.”

“I think so too! Let’s just leave the jjimjilbang as a nice memory of the past!”

Some merpeople felt resentful when they read the signup form. Some were enraged. They enjoyed relaxing their muscles and joints with heat, but this was too much. It was a direct mockery to all merpeople. So, they scoffed, arguing that they’ve been living without the jjimjilbang just fine and that they’ll survive without it well enough. Every one of them agreed and left in a rage, resolving that they would never ever use the facility again. They coldly went away, and that day, not a single one of them signed up. As such, the jjimjilbang became silent for the first time in a while. The red clay room, which once bustled with merpeople, was now still. The seawater room and the tropical beach sand room that the merpeople loved for their familiar charm and exotic vibe, respectively, were only occupied by deep-sea plankton.

“It appears that we have failed.” Javier, unable to hold any longer, crinkled his brow.

“I don’t think so,” disagreed Lloyd, shrugging his shoulders. “Things will change in a few days.”

“How will it change?”

“Wait, and you will see.” Lloyd grinned.

Lloyd was confident. He was confident that even though the merpeople had initially turned away in frustration after reading the membership form, the situation would change in the next few days. So, he simply waited without a hint of doubt in his head. As time passed, the merpeople were still angry, and Lloyd was still confident. One day. Two days. Four days. Six days later. On that sixth day, at last, the merpeople realized. They were forced to admit it. They had to admit that they could not live without the jjimjilbang anymore.

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Chapter 266: Mermaids Love Jjimjilbangs (5)

Addiction. A state of being so intensely into something that you couldn't stop doing whatever that was. It made quitting extremely difficult. A case in point was smoking, which most people started by taking a drag of a cigarette out of curiosity until it developed into a full-blown addiction that they couldn't stop. In an attempt to take care of their health and quit, they would try the nicotine replacement items, such as gums and inhalers, until those became yet another addiction, this time only more expensive. There were also cryptocurrencies and stocks, wherein people just couldn't wrench their gaze away from their phones, even during meals, because market prices might shoot up. Lastly, there were video and PC games. After three days of not playing, an addict would start seeing the summoner's rift in their dreams. All these examples highlighted what addiction did to people. And the Mermaid Kingdom was no exception.

"Golly, my entire body is sore," grumbled one granny mermaid as she tapped her back with her ripped forearm. Each tap produced a loud thudding noise, much like hitting a drum. A look of dissatisfaction appeared on her face. Her back was in a great deal of pain.

Whew... I did too many dolphin kicks back when I was young! Tsk, tsk.

A wave of regret washed over the old mermaid. There was a time when her skin was tight, her muscles were firm, and she could ram into emperor whales unharmed. She mistakenly thought that her muscles would last forever and her firm, robust body would always remain strong for tens and thousands of years. But over the years, she learned that wasn't the case. Her entire body ached as soon as she hit 60 due to the strain that her gigantic muscles placed on her joints. And now, she was faced with a hellish case of arthritis.

"That sauna was very relaxing," she remarked with a tinge of nostalgia in her voice. "Don't you agree, honey?"

"Hohoho," her husband laughed boisterously. "Well, I was happy to not hear your nagging while you were at the jjimjilbang."

“Dear?” she growled and shot a look at him.

“Hmm?” replied her husband innocently.

“Are you tired of living with me?” Her eyes held a glint of anger.

“Hmm! Hmm! Ehem!” The grandpa merman hurriedly looked away, sensing danger. This deepened the wrinkles on the grandma mermaid’s face.

Whew. I wonder if there is any way the both of us could use a sauna one way or another.

She was wistful. She was happy when she was relaxing at the jjimjilbang. Her sickening joint aches could be forgotten there. But not anymore, to her utmost displeasure.

This is all because of that cheap, cold-hearted land human!

The human that constructed and ran the jjimjilbang. What was his name? Lloyd Frontera? The more her thoughts dwelled on him, the more critical she became of him.

Of course, the jjimjilbang can’t be free. He needs to receive a fee. Of course. But why does it have to be the labor of all things?! Tsk, tsk!

She’d have understood if he wanted pearls or precious clam shells. But no. The payment had to come in the form of labor hours for that human Lloyd. Otherwise, the jjimjilbang was off-limits. That was the reason why she had ripped the seaweed paper containing the terms and conditions of membership and stomped out of the jjimjilbang, foaming at her mouth. But now? Just within a few days, she began to regret her decision.

I thought I could live without it.

She was confident she’d forget the jjimjilbang after a few days and easily move on with life. But now, it turned out that wasn’t the case. Instead of forgetting it, it kept coming back to her. Its vacancy left a hole in her heart that she couldn’t live with.

This won’t do.

The granny mermaid jumped to her feet.

“Honey,” she called, “This won’t do. Stay here for a second.”

“Eh? Where are you going?”

“To the jjimjilbang.”

She herself was unsure what she’d do by going there. However, it didn’t feel right just to stay stuck at home while massaging her aching joints.

But, of course, I am not going to go use the facility and be pulled into his game.

She would just take a quick look around. That was what she’d do. There might be other merpeople like her in the same agony. Those who might be swimming around the jjimjilbang in remorse and regret like her.

I’ll just take a small peek. That’s all.

The granny mermaid was convinced that there would be no one at the jjimjilbang. There was no reason for anyone to be hovering nearby. No one in the kingdom would be as foolish as her. That was what she thought until...

What is this...

Suddenly, she felt a shaft of numbness. It turned out the jjimjilbang area was far from quiet. It was bustling with merpeople! So many merpeople were there! What was more...

“Oh my! Is that you, dear? You’re finally here!” Another granny mermaid, who was passing by with many others, beamed when she saw the old mermaid that had just arrived. They waved their fins, approached her, and rapped her shoulders. They were her friends, who were only a few years younger and would hang out with her often.

“What on earth are you all doing here?” inquired the wistful granny, her voice sharp and edgy.

“Why else?” One of them remarked. “We are here to enjoy the sauna.”

The muscles on her face tensed. “Since when have you been coming here?”

“Us? We’ve been coming here since yesterday.”

The wistful granny mermaid froze, and she didn’t respond.

“Dear?”

“You ungrateful and disloyal bunch of mermaids,” she snarled at last before wheeling around to leave.

“There, there, my dear,” one of them grabbed her. “No need to get upset. Come over here. I will massage your back. No need to pout. It will only leave wrinkles on your pretty lips. Okay?”

With that, the rest of the younger mermaids cackled and chortled as they pushed the angry granny mermaid’s back. The latter feigned her reluctance to enter by grumbling to the group, but her lips were faintly rolled upward. And with that, she processed her membership at lightning speed. Lloyd, who was manning the counter, beamed, his rewarding smile as clear and bright as a jam-packed portion of salted pollack roe.

Mwahaha. Everything is going according to plan.

In no exaggeration, it was a complete success. Lloyd cast his satisfying gaze at the table, which was piled up with a thick pile of sign-up scrolls. And his gaze then moved to the inside of the facility. It was packed with merpeople. Not a single room was vacant. The red clay room. The seawater room and sandy beach room. The extreme bungee-jump room. The merpeople were even competing to get their place. A similar sight to what he saw during the opening event for the jjimjilbang. No. There was one small thing that changed.

“Yo, Javier,” called Lloyd as he tapped the pile of scrolls.

“Yes,” said Javier, who was standing by Lloyd’s side beside the counter.

“Why don’t you go around and check the jjimjilbang rooms?”

“Check what, Master Lloyd?”

“The luminescent coral.” Lloyd’s eyes shone acutely. “There should be a few merpeople who’ve stayed here for six hours now. The luminescence on the coral around their wrist should be faded by now. Ask them if they’re going to charge it or go back home for today.”

“I see. But...” There was a heaviness in his hesitant voice.

“What’s up?”

“Do you plan on using me as a clerk now?”

“Yes.” It took him less than a second to respond.

“...”

“Look at you,” said Lloyd as he amusingly pointed his finger at Javier. “There, you’re doing it again. You’re glaring at me. Come on,” said Lloyd in an almost entreating tone. “It’s just for now. Do you see this? I’m writing a job posting. Free jjimjilbang entry while on call. Merpeople will pounce at this opportunity. Sure, it’ll take time for me to do interviews and look for the most diligent merperson out of the pool. However, I’ll pick someone soon. You got nothing to worry about.”

“Whew... I see, Master Lloyd.”

Javier sighed and started to move around, which caused an eruption of cheers from the merpeople watching him. Everyone had a wristband that contained a lump of glowing, deep-sea coral. It was designed to glow for exactly six hours, and the merpeople were given two choices when the light went out. They could extend their stay for six more hours and fill up the daily 12-hour limit or leave the facility. Those who chose the latter were asked to record their time of stay in their membership log as they left the facility to calculate the number of hours they would need to work.

“Thank you very much for visiting the deep-sea cave jjimjilbang!” shouted Lloyd.

“Not at all.” A mermaid stopped when she heard him and approached Lloyd. “Um, does this mean that I have to do my assigned work within 48 hours, just as the terms and conditions state?”

“Indeed,” Lloyd replied. “That’s exactly right.” She was a young mermaid who had just completed her first-ever sauna visit. Lloyd flashed a big smile at her. “The work site will be announced tomorrow morning, and it will be posted on the bulletin board at the jjimjilbang entrance. You can complete your labor hours according to what is written there.”

“Is there anything I should prepare in advance?” she inquired, her voice sounding anxious.

“All you need to bring is your strong body.”

Lloyd’s answer must have taken her by surprise. “My strong... body?” Her voice trembled.

“Yes. Is there anything else you need?”

“No... I understand now.”

Lloyd smiled benevolently, but the young mermaid felt a clawing sense of nervousness. The following day, the excavation began.

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“Ehem...!” Lloyd cleared his throat to have attention drawn to himself. “Thank you very much for gathering here to pay for the jjimjilbang. As I have introduced myself before, I am Lloyd Frontera, the owner of the jjimjilbang. But today, I will be your supervisor who oversees the excavation site.”

Among about 120 merpeople gathered at the site in the early morning, one raised their hand.

“Excuse me? Excavation? What do you mean?”

“Exactly as it sounds,” Lloyd explained, “From now on, we will be shoveling to find something in the bottom of the sea.”

“Shoveling?!” the merperson repeated in shock.

“Yes, shoveling.” Lloyd nonchalantly nodded before holding up one of the clam-shell shovels he had prepared by piles in advance. They weren’t the typical shovels used at construction sites on land. They looked like those used for cleaning snow.

“This is the shovel you will be using today,” continued Lloyd, “To dig up the mud in the area I designate for all of you.”

“How will we know where to dig?” One of the gatherers inquired.

“No worries. Look over there.” Lloyd then pointed at one area.

Bzzt! A glowing straight blue line started to appear, following Lloyd’s fingers until each met and connected with one another. About 0.6 miles long and wide, it soon formed a gigantic square. This was the work of the Construction Guideline, one of the optional skills Lloyd had. The merpeople watched in sheer amazement, their eyes growing wide, and wondered if this human was a magician. They murmured among themselves and looked at each other until Lloyd’s voice interrupted them.

“Now, you can see the line I just drew for you at the bottom. Shovel the mud within the square area and get it clean. Oh, but please be careful not to break the shovel. And you must log the hours you worked. Don’t forget. If you forget to log your hours, all your hard work will be good for nothing.”

Gulp. Those last words made the merpeople tense up. Everyone resolved to log their hours of work on the card. They had to log their hours no matter what. And with that, the excavation to find the site of the jewel began.

“Okay, let’s get started!” announced Lloyd with a clap.

“Wooo!!!”

120 merpeople took action with a clam shovel in their hands. Their monstrous physique gave them a tremendous aptitude for shoveling. They swam at a speed that even dolphins couldn’t keep up with. And just like that, they pierced through the mud.

Crack! The clam shovels dug deep into the seabed, and it went in deep, much like how a bull would graze the land.

“Gwoahhh!”

Boooom! When five merpeople scratched the bottom first, a giant hole, 20 inches deep and 9.8 feet wide, appeared. Then the next five followed right away.

“Gwoahhh!”

Boooom! They dug into the same hole one more time. It went in deeper this time. Then another five came to work on the same hole. This process was repeated, the mud turning over at a marvelous speed. Lloyd found himself clenching his fists at the exhilarating sight.

This is nuts! This is totally nuts!

Their shoveling speed went beyond his imagination. Lloyd was always aware of their strength and stamina, but seeing them himself, it turned out they were better. It was like having 120 bulldozers turn over and work on the earth. Of course, Lloyd didn’t just sit back and watch while everything was unfolding.

Surveying!

[Scanning will begin.]

Bzzt!

Lloyd activated his surveying skill toward the seabed the merpeople dug, and it allowed him to look 16 feet underground.

Great. I can see deeper than before.

Since the merpeople were ridding of the thick mud carpet, Lloyd was able to take a look beneath the mud. But he couldn’t find the jewel site right away.

“Okay!” shouted Lloyd. “Let’s work harder! You may be sweating from work today, but you will be sweating at the jjimjilbang tomorrow!”

“Wooo!!!” The merpeople worked more energetically at Lloyd’s encouragement. They dug, dug, and dug until their muscles began to feel fatigued. Naturally, their worn-out muscles started to fill their head with one thing.

Whew, this is tiring. Should I stop by at the jjimjilbang before heading home and relax for just a little bit?

Like that, most merpeople headed back to the jjimjilbang after work instead of heading home. And then they found themselves being welcomed by Lloyd, who was just back at the construction site to supervise the labor. But this time, he was before them as the owner of the jjimjilbang.

“My! Welcome, my dear customers!” beamed Lloyd with a delightful smile on his face.

The merpeople sensed something was wrong but soon pushed away the thought and decided to hit the bath and sauna pronto, relieving their pent-up fatigue after a day of labor. The next day, however, they had to sweat and work again to pay for enjoying the facility the previous day, only for the drudgery at the site to helplessly remind them of the relaxing bath and sauna. And so, they unwound at the jjimjilbang again, which only spelled more gruesome work. Work. Unwind. Work. Unwind. It was an endless cycle. The merpeople finally came to a realization.

What should I do? I can’t... free myself from this vicious cycle!

They relaxed in the jjimjilbang. They toiled until fatigue ushered them back into the facility again. And another toil was due. Yes. This was a vicious cycle, a drug that was impossible to stop! And just like that, while the merpeople were stuck in a cycle of working and going to the jjimjilbang,

the construction site ran very smoothly under Lloyd’s command. The number of merpeople he pulled in through his plan increased, and their excavation range grew larger with each passing day. The range for Lloyd’s surveying also expanded just as much. And two months later...

Oh...!

At last, something caught his eye.

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Chapter 267: Distinguish Yourself (1)

Moments of realization often came without any warning. There were many of these moments throughout history. For instance, when Archimedes shouted, "Eureka!" after discovering the principle of buoyancy, when Galileo Galilei discovered the moons orbiting around Jupiter, or when someone found a 50-dollar bill in their coat after a year. Big and small discoveries emerged at the most unexpected times. And today. Lloyd, too, experienced this same phenomenon.

Oh...?

Lloyd opened his eyes wide. It had been two months since he supervised the construction site. Every day, hundreds of merpeople were mobilized to sweep and search the seabed of the Arctic Ocean. But nothing was found even with Lloyd’s surveying and subterranean scanning skill as they diligently removed countless layers of mud. They couldn’t find a single artifact, let alone the location of the jewel. As he was starting to grow tired, something began to emerge.

It can’t be.

He wasn’t very far from the Mermaid Kingdom, and this location looked nothing special on the outside. It was just a vast plain under the sea. But as soon as the merpeople cleared the mud, his surveying skill caught something beneath the ground.

There’s a stratum, but this looks too sleek. It’s almost like the structure was man-made.

When that realization hit him, Lloyd yelled, “Wait! Everybody stop working!”

The busy shoveling came to a halt. Lloyd removed everyone at the site, and he furrowed his brows, putting his eyes into focus. He carefully walked toward the area where the artificial stratum was. Once he got close, he was able to get a more detailed view.

I’m sure of it. That looks like a stratum, but it’s not that. This is some sort of foundation constructed by man.

About 10 feet below the cleared seabed, there appeared a strange-looking foundation. It had a perfectly square shape as if someone had poured cement on the ground. In particular, the upper area was excessively sleek to the point that it seemed unnatural. So, that could only be...

I think it’s the foundation of a building. But doesn’t seem to be made of rebar concrete. Hmm, I wonder if this is the result of stacking flat and smooth rocks together.

It appeared so. His heart started to race.

He said that the Jewel of Truth was a building.

Perhaps that really could be the foundation of the Jewel of Truth. It seemed that the two months they spent on excavation weren’t meaningless after all.

If we’ve found the location of the jewel’s site, then the most important part is what we do from here on out.

Lloyd’s eyes became focused. And he became more mindful of his movements with the shovel.

Psh! Crack! He dug the seafloor. Heavily at first. But around the time the foundation was about to reveal itself, he moved with even more caution like he was scooping up a grain of rice. And for the final sweep, he used his hands to dust the top portion of the foundation. Sometime later, he finally succeeded in exposing most of the top portion without any damage.

“This is the real one...” murmured Lloyd as he rose.

Lloyd instantly knew now that he could see the foundation up close. This wasn’t a natural formation. It was a foundation built by someone with a clear purpose in mind.

This could be the foundation for the Jewel of Truth.

Lloyd’s eyes became more focused. Now that he confirmed it was a man-made structure, it was time to check whether it was truly a part of the Jewel of Truth.

“Um, Mister Rotorua?” called Lloyd aloud.

“Yeah? Yeah?!” Rotorua, who was nervously observing Lloyd from afar, immediately swam to Lloyd’s side when he was called.

“What do you think this is?” asked Lloyd as he pointed at the ground.

Rotorua observed before he finally said, “I have no idea, but...”

“But what?” hurried Lloyd.

“If this is the one we are looking for, there should be a symbol somewhere on this foundation. The records tell us so.”

“What symbol?”

“One that looks like a starfish with sharp edges.”

“I see.” Lloyd and Rotorua started dusting every surface in search of the symbol. Several minutes later...

I found it!

Indeed, there it was. At the corner of the foundation was a starfish symbol as big as the palm of his hand. Yet to be satisfied with the finding, Lloyd’s gaze continued to move across the surface of the structure.

Of course. There’s more I need to do than just discover the location of the jewel.

Lloyd wasn’t an archeologist. Discovering the Jewel of the Truth site and discussing its academic values and whatnot were entirely irrelevant to Lloyd. What he needed was the Jewel of Truth that could be used immediately, not just its foundation structure.

I have to find the blueprint.

Lloyd turned and said, “Um, Mister Rotorua?”

But when Lloyd turned around, to his surprise, he found Rotorua wailing and crying his heart out.

“Stop crying and look at me,” demanded Lloyd.

Rotorua nodded and tried to control himself, only to give way to overwhelming emotions again. “I... It’s just... I feel overwhelmed...” He sniffled heavily in between his words.

Could it be due to the joy of finding the site of the jewel at last? Rotorua was weeping his heart out as he clapped his face with his hands, like someone who won their first lottery ticket amidst drowning in crippling rent and loans. Lloyd eventually let Rotorua have his moment until he calmed down.

“Ehem. Hmm! I am sorry for the sudden display of emotions,” Rotorua finally said in an embarrassed voice. He wiped his eyes.

“Don’t be,” comforted Lloyd, “I fully understand you. But the thing is, didn’t you say that the blueprint would be here at the site?”

“Oh, I did.”

“Then where is it?”

The blueprint was the most important thing here. Finding the site location was only half of the job. The Jewel of Truth could only be restored to its original shape with a blueprint. Only then could Lloyd ask the jewel about how to stop the restoration of destiny.

Without it, everything would have been a waste.

But there was nothing in sight that remotely looked like a blueprint. Nervousness started to creep up on Lloyd. Rotorua, on the other hand, was unperturbed.

“Oh,” Rotorua said in a casual voice, “The blueprint is here. The record says that it is right here.” He then pointed at the starfish symbol. “The record about the symbol was discovered by one of my ancestors in the sixteenth generation of my family. According to it, the blueprint is said to be hidden in the starfish symbol.”

“In this symbol?” asked Lloyd.

“Yes. All it needs is just some pressure... Let’s see.” Rotorua dropped to a crouch and started to run his hands over the symbol before he pressed the center of it.

Clack.

And then...

Ruuumble! Like a morning alarm, the foundation structure started to vibrate with great force, which caused a resonation in the seawater around them. The tremors gradually traveled farther and farther across the ground.

“Oh, wow.”

Lloyd clenched his fists at the magnificent resonation shaking the entire sea. This grand effect could only mean that he succeeded in finding what he was looking for. An ember of hope was ignited in his heart. But at the same hour, miles away from the excavation site, a mysterious resonation began to occur in the stomach of the Kraken, the gigantic octopus that protected the eggs that contained the whole kingdom.

***

Voooooooo!

“K-Krurung?”

The Kraken was utterly shocked. How could it not? It was in the middle of a peaceful nap, going about its day like usual, when a violent vibration assaulted its stomach.

“Krung? Krurung?”

It was flustered. Its stomach knotted up, but it didn’t know why. It didn’t know that an object was lodged in between the villus of its fifth stomach. The object resonated in line with the vibration of the jewel’s foundation from miles away. The Kraken was utterly clueless about what was happening and seriously dismayed.

“Krururng! Krung! Krung!”

It coughed aloud and even violently shook its body. Still, the forceful and sudden tremors didn’t lessen. No. It only grew more tumultuous. It was a stifling feeling as if its stomach and intestines were tangled in a knot.

“Krurung!”

The Kraken’s screams grew louder. The strong yearning to move violently and writhe up and down rushed over the octopus. That seemed like a good way to alleviate the excruciating and splitting pain inside it. The Kraken deliberated until it reached a conclusion. It must not move mindlessly. Moving the mountainous body that wrapped the eggs of the Mermaid Kingdom would only inflict severe damage to the place. As such, the Kraken frantically struggled to endure the pain.

“K-Krurung!”

It roared. It flexed its stomach to suppress the churning. But later, it reached the point where it couldn’t endure the sensation any longer.

Voooooooo! The resonation in its fifth stomach became fiercer. The vibration was so fierce and terrifying that its desperate will couldn’t contain the octopus any longer.

“Krurung!”

At last, its body, which was over several miles long, convulsed reflexively to the pain. Soon, the eggs that contained the city of the merpeople scattered

in all directions after being separated from the octopus’s tentacles that were wrapped around them.

***

Boooom!

“Eh...?” Queen Kiakora stopped dead in her tracks. She was deliberating on the matter of the Hell gate opening up in the sky and ways to solve the problem when the egg that contained the palace was hit with a great force. *Thump! Boooom!*

“What is happening?”

A look of dismay came over her face. The whole palace tilted to one side. No, she realized that it was not the palace but the whole egg that contained the palace that was thrown off balance. Just then…

“My queen! The outside of the egg! Something terrible has happened!” One of the servants hurriedly swam to her side, and in an urgent voice, she added, “The Kraken! It has started to go berserk!”

“What?!” shrieked the queen. “The Kraken?”

“Yes, Your Majesty! We do not know the cause. It was said that it screamed several times and started to writhe its entire body and go berserk!”

“How could this be happening...?” The queen furrowed her brows. The report was hard to believe. The Kraken was an old friend of her people. It had been with the merpeople for several generations, long before she hatched out of her egg.

The Kraken was hatched on the same day as the most respected queen Houhora and they grew up together. It even fought with us shoulder to shoulder in the expeditionary battle in the desert during our punitive expedition against the dragon, Kaisertus. It has been protecting us ever since then for generations. And now it is going on a rampage?

She couldn’t wrap her head around this. Was it betrayal? A sudden awakening of its wild instincts? That made even less sense.

There must be a reason.

The Kraken would never run amok without a reason. It wasn’t the kind to harm the race this thoughtlessly. Having drawn such a conclusion, the queen ordered in a calm voice, “I see. But since it appears it is not safe here, everyone must evacuate. Now.”

“I will get to it right away, Your Majesty!”

At her command, the servants around her sides and the guards darted out of the palace. They swam faster than they ever had in their entire lives. Once they swam out of the egg, they were able to get a full view of the situation.

“The eggs of the kingdom are...”

They were all scattering away. Like pollack eggs thrown into a fast current of water, hundreds and thousands of eggs that had been held tightly together were being scattered away, each drifting, falling, rolling, and crashing. There was only one cause for this.

“Krurung!”

The Kraken was roaring and going berserk. It was violently wielding its eight legs that used to grip the eggs into one tight case and twisting and turning its body that extended over a few miles long. Its terrible writhing caused the eggs to disperse across the sea and be sucked into a violent current of water.

Whoosh! Just then, one of the eggs was caught in the current hurtled in the queen’s direction. With a diameter of over 650 feet, it was a pretty big one among the city eggs.

“My queen!”

“Duck!” The servants on both of her sides shrilled in panic, but the queen didn’t listen to them. Although she was slightly dazed by the overwhelming

and unexpected violence of the Kraken, she soon recovered from her shock.

“Hmph!” She gave a rough snort, and a glint of resolution appeared in her eyes as she glared at the egg flying in her way. Anaconda-thick veins bulged in her forearm, biceps, triceps, and delts, and soon her chest, stomach, and back popped as though an armor was put on her. And she immediately hurtled toward the egg.

“As if I could turn a blind eye and swim away when the land of my people is flying at me!” She opened her arms wide and took the brunt of the egg with her pecs.

Boooom! Having received the full force of the 656-foot egg loaded with buildings, her body was shoved about 320 yards backward. Even so, she kept moving her fins at an explosive speed and with incredible power.

“Argh... Ah... Aaargh!!”

Rumble...! The veins all over her body now thickened like a python, but still, the egg was relentless, doggedly shoving the queen back with its ferocious speed and weight.

“Arggh!”

The queen’s face reddened, and right at the moment when the thought of being crushed to death crossed her mind...

“My queen!”

Suddenly, she heard someone shout beside her. She reflexively looked at her side as her body trembled from head to toe. And then she saw who it was.

“I may not be much, but I will help you!!! Argh!!!”

It was the man from the land. Lloyd Frontera. He was at her side, stopping the egg with both hands. He looked desperate to provide aid to her, and his whole body screamed, “I am going to help you!”

“Human?” she panted, “Why? But you are a foreigner.”

“If you’re asking me why I’m helping out! My answer is that I have no reason!”

“No reason?”

“Yes, Your Majesty! “What reason do you need to help someone in crisis?!” Lloyd yelled louder. His response tugged at her heartstrings. Of course, she was left completely in the dark about one thing. She had no idea that Lloyd was pretending to help by barely touching the egg. She was unaware that Lloyd was faking it. She was clueless that, even amid this unexpected turn of events, Lloyd had a scheme in mind.

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Chapter 268: Distinguish Yourself (2)

“What reason do you need to help someone in crisis?!”

“...”

Lloyd’s unexpected response surprised Queen Kiakora, and she clamped her mouth shut. She fell into a daze.

This human. Who is he?

Just then, the warnings of the previous generations of queens came to her mind. Do not trust the land humans. They are absolute opportunists. If something involves money or benefits them, they don’t even think twice about betraying their friends and anyone else. But then, at the prospect of another gain, they’ll team up again. They are an incorrigible existence. That was what all of her ancestors had advised.

But this human...

He seemed slightly different from what she was told. Even though they were faced with an extremely precarious situation, this human named Lloyd Frontera immediately rushed and stood by her side to hold up the gigantic egg with her. This situation and undeniable fact brought a flood of emotions to her heart.

“All right. Human Lloyd Frontera. I will accept your help.”

“Thank you so much!” shouted Lloyd, recognizing a slight tremble in the queen’s voice. He wondered if it was because she was straining to use all of her strength or because she was filled with gratitude toward him. Whatever it was, a proud smile hung on Lloyd’s face.

Great. That’s one big crisis avoided. At least for now.

Lloyd quickly stole a glance at the queen. Red-faced. Pumped muscles. She was giving her all to stop this gigantic ball of an egg. Whereas he was...

standing next to her with his arms also outstretched to push against the egg. However, more precisely, he was only pretending as he just touched the egg with his hands and let out groans of struggle. Of course, there was a reason behind Lloyd's actions.

Of course. I don't know what exactly happened, but the monster started to go wild after I discovered the foundation of the jewel. It was at the same time as when the vibrations began.

Just then, Lloyd's mind flew back to the previous events. He finally discovered the foundation of the jewel. Rotorua fidgeted it around to activate the blueprint. It was a success. And then came a rumbling noise and powerful vibration. The water around the foundation fiercely trembled. Lloyd was very certain of it. He had found the Jewel of Truth. He was happy. But his happiness was short-lived.

The Kraken went on a rampage.

Although he was several miles away from the Mermaid Kingdom, Lloyd got a vivid look at the Kraken in a frenzy. It was because of the subtle glow in the eggs that made up the Mermaid Kingdom.

The Kraken roared, and it started to dance as if it was going mad.

In the wake of that, the eggs were crushed into pieces and scattered across the water. The sight was akin to a portion of salted pollack roe falling apart from someone's clumsy attempt at using chopsticks.

And I dashed here as soon as I caught sight of what was happening.

His instinct tingled as soon as he saw the Kraken going rampant. The resonance from activating the foundation of the jewel was related to what was happening at the moment. The timing was too perfect for Lloyd to dismiss it. It was very likely he might be held responsible for the Kraken's savage behavior and the Mermaid Kingdom's possible demise.

It was Rotorua who activated it, but I, too, am responsible since I supervised the job. So I can't turn a blind eye now.

Did he feel a sense of responsibility? Fixing what was wrong? Neither of the two reasons was his reason for helping.

Like I care about taking responsibility! I just don't want to get killed by the queen, who'll for sure throw a punch to my gut once she finds out I'm the one behind this mess!

That scenario was plausible enough. What if a future investigation revealed that the cause behind this chaos was the excavation of the jewel's lot? The merpeople would demand Lloyd to be held liable. If that happened, he'd have no excuses for his guilt.

Obviously, I won't be able to exonerate myself. I was the one who ran the jjimjilbang and mobilized the merpeople to the site. And hundreds of merpeople were there when the jewel was discovered. They'll act as witnesses. This means that I can't bury this incident even if I want to.

So what would happen if things settled down at the current flow of events and the time came to clarify who needed to be held responsible? Lloyd believed justice would be served, and he would take the full blow.

That's why I'm buttering her up in advance! I'll pretend to actively offer my support to resolve this mess and gain some merit! This way, I'll earn some brownie points from her too!

That would minimize the amount of criticism he'd receive down the road and allow him to avoid getting his gut-punched by the queen. And at the least, he wouldn't be banished from the kingdom.

I can't be banished after finally finding the jewel's lot.

He had discovered the jewel after a great length of struggle and couldn't get himself kicked out of this place. When he thought about all the time and effort he'd assiduously invested until now, he had to do something to avoid getting expelled from this kingdom. After making some calculations, Lloyd yelled, "My queen! Please push a little harder! On my count!"

"Argh!" Queen Kiakora groaned. "On your count?!"

“Yes! So, push harder when I tell you! Push!”

“Argh!” Her veins were enlarged.

“Push!”

“Gargh!” Lloyd shouted while pretending to flex his muscles, cheering the queen on. It was similar to the sudden surge of strength that occurred when a personal trainer at a gym supported someone using a bell bar to get in another rep or as if a supernatural force was helping someone lift a 44-lb weight at the gym. The egg started to slow down at last.

Grrrr...

“We’re doing good! A little more! One!” Lloyd bawled.

“Arggh!” she boomed.

“Push!”

“Gargh!!”

Boom!

The queen’s pecs and triceps inflated as if they were ready to burst. And at last, the tyrannous egg stopped, proving once again the monstrous strength and majestic nature of the queen, the leader of the incredibly ripped race of merpeople.

“Ha... Ha...” panted Lloyd, wiping his forehead for effect. “Your Majesty, are you all right?”

“Of course,” replied the queen as she looked back at Lloyd. Her face was still red. She placed her pot-like rough hand on Lloyd’s shoulder. “I was this close to being crushed into the ground. Thank you. It could have been dangerous without your help.”

“Whew!” panted Lloyd still. “Do not be, Your Majesty. I merely supported you with my small amount of strength.” Lloyd pretended to collect his

breath. It was a relief.

One egg was stopped. Moreover, it appeared that the queen hadn’t seen through him.

Great. I earned some brownie points from her for now.

But he needed much more. Much more brownie points, and more good impressions. That would be the only way he could use the jewel without getting lashed out by the merpeople.

That means I’ll have to accomplish something greater to solve this problem.

Lloyd’s calm gaze raked over the Kraken. Its trunk was so large, it was impossible to determine the size. Similarly, its legs were much too thick and long to estimate the measurements.

“Krururung!”

At another roar, the whole sea shook. Each time it twisted its body, more eggs bounced off in all directions. Lloyd felt a pang of remorse that was as bitter as a cup of espresso.

This chaos looks impossible to resolve.

That was how different the scale of the commotion was. And yet, the courage among the merpeople was also on a level beyond Lloyd’s expectations.

“Sisters! Rise!”

“Sister! Take my hand!”

“Brother! Trust me and grab me tight!”

Every merperson acted with composure, despite that they were unexpectedly thrown into this unprecedented commotion by the Kraken, the guardian of their city. They weren’t in a state of terror. Instead, they took charge of the situation, uniting as one.

“Everyone! I’m sure we all saw the example set by the queen! Let us follow her lead!”

“Wooo!!!”

Hundreds of merpeople teamed up to save the flying eggs and rescued the merpeople floundering inside them. The rescued individuals recuperated soon and joined in on the ongoing effort. And within 30 minutes, the merpeople safely managed to save thousands of eggs and their residential areas, placing all of them at the bottom of the sea. Then they encircled the frenzied Kraken together. However, they didn’t resort to violence right away.

Of course! The Kraken is our friend!

Even though its anomalous behavior damaged their houses and scattered tens of thousands of eggs, which translates to back-breaking labor and exorbitant money for reconstruction, the merpeople regarded the sea monster as their friend. They believed that this was an honest mistake and that there must be a reason behind its troubling behavior. And so, they agreed that it had to be appeased first. They gathered around, and in the most genuine manner, they sang, forming a choir of merpeople. Their melody softly caressed the sea and comforted the Kraken. Lloyd, who was seeing this, became keenly aware of one thing.

“They can’t sing, either!” Lloyd yelled, which came out inadvertently. He thought it was unfair.

What the heck! Their tune and rhythm are completely wrong! They didn’t have any right to judge me for being a bad singer!

Truly, their singing was horrendous. If they were brought to karaoke in South Korea, they would have enough energy to make the tambourines and flashing lights in the room seem dull. Anyone listening to them would want to divert their attention toward something else, such as a leaflet, remote controller, or a poster with the top song chart on the wall. But before Lloyd could voice out his bitterness, he was interrupted by the queen.

“They cannot sing, huh?” mused Queen Kiakora. “To your human ears, does our singing sound bad?”

“Oh, eh? That’s...” mumbled Lloyd, rebuking himself for forgetting the queen nearby.

“But you just shouted that they cannot.” Her gaze bore into Lloyd.

“Ahaha,” Lloyd quickly worked on his face to hide his emotion. “To be honest, I said so because I felt a sense of camaraderie.”

The queen cocked her head to the side. “Camaraderie?”

“I, too, am considered tone-deaf in my world.”

“Are you now?” Her tone indicated she wasn’t very convinced.

“Yes,” said Lloyd with a nod.

“But you seemed very upset a moment ago.”

“Yes. I couldn’t help but remember the judgmental gazes I received from others in the past...” Lloyd observed her face, and before the queen could say anything, he butt in as he pointed at the Kraken. “Oh, look! It looks like the singing isn’t comforting the monster!”

It was true. At first, the song seemed to calm the monster down, but that was only for a second.

“Krurung! Krung!”

Could it be that something else was bothering the monster? It twisted its body like a snake and roared, this time moving even more uncontrollably than before. The mermaid queen’s face darkened.

“The Kraken... refused our request for reconciliation.”

Could she be feeling the same rejection you feel when your trusted friend refuses to handshake you? There was sadness in her hard and stern gaze.

“Human Lloyd Frontera, step back.” Her voice was cold and emotionless.

“Pardon? What do you plan on doing?” asked Lloyd.

“Plan, my foot. Now that the Kraken has refused, we must fight.”

“Fight? With that thing?”

“Yes,” the queen replied with a wistful look on her face. “Our friend is going mad. We tried to reason with it, but that didn’t work. What should come next?”

“Um,” observed Lloyd, “Roll up your sleeves and suppress it?”

“Yes. That is my plan.”

Fwipp! As soon as she was done talking, she moved her fin for some powerful dolphin kicks, creating a whirling storm around that sucked everything, including Lloyd.

Ack!

It felt as though he was being thrown into a dryer. Lloyd was only able to recover his position after Javier came to the rescue. Meanwhile, the queen was already miles away from him.

“Kru-rururung! Krung!” Its roar terrorized the deep sea.

The Mermaid Corps formed a file to fight against their friend. In minutes, the Kraken and the Mermaid Corps, who both used to be friends, were about to clash. Why? All because Lloyd had activated the foundation of the jewel. But he wasn’t the type to feel guilty about it. To be technically correct, he didn’t have the time to feel guilty.

It can’t let a fight develop like this. If the jewel’s foundation gets destroyed... Then I’m screwed!

Lloyd became a bundle of nerves as he imagined it happening in his head. He knew that this concern was very likely to happen.

The jewel's foundation is just a few miles away from where we're at.

It wasn't actually that close, at least from Lloyd's perspective. But from the Kraken's perspective, it sure was.

The Kraken can reach the lot by outstretching just one of its legs just like when someone reaches for the TV remote control in front of them from their sofa.

With just one stretch of its leg, it would be able to touch the jewel's lot. And if that happened, the foundation of the jewel would easily break like a potato chip under a pair of dress shoes. It would get crushed in one blow. And along with it, his solution to find a way to stop the restoration of destiny from plaguing his life would get crushed.

That can't happen!!

Lloyd shook his head as he let his imagination fly.

I have to prevent a clash between them. But what should I do? What am I supposed to do?

Lloyd's clenched fists started to get sweaty. He racked his brain for a solution, going over the events in his head. The Kraken started to go on a rampage after the resonation flew out from the jewel site. And it wouldn't listen to the merpeople's soft words of persuasion and restraint. Now, the Mermaid Corps was seconds away from laying an all-out attack. Seeing them, Lloyd cudgeled his brain, observing the situation for any clues, even a small one. And at that moment...

"Kru-rururung! Krung... Krugh! Krung!"

Tumble! The Kraken's whole body gave a strange, sudden jerk as it roared within the merpeople's net. And then it let out a familiar noise at the end of its roar.

Buuurp!..

"..."

Just then, a thought crossed Lloyd’s mind.

“Wait, did it just burp?”

Ding! A light bulb lit up in his head! The burping, writhing, and commotion. The Kraken’s behaviors started to piece together in his head, and from then on, he had a realization. He saw where the octopus’s legs were tapping itself and the silent gesture it made as it writhed. And the seemingly intentional burping. When he put everything together, he recalled a familiar experience he had. At last, he found the answer.

Hold on. Does the Kraken have an upset stomach?!

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Chapter 269: How to Treat an Upset Stomach (1)

An upset stomach. It was a painful experience everyone had at some point in their lives. It came at the most unexpected moments without any warning. Your stomach suddenly churned before making you tap your midsection in a desperate attempt to facilitate digestion and whatnot. Lloyd, too, experienced this before.

It was during a high school field trip. Dammit.

The mere recollection of the event made him shudder. It must have been the first night. He was about to hang out with his friends after dinner when his stomach started to feel weird. At first, he didn't think much about it. But his bowel situation grew worse, making him nauseous and break out in a cold sweat. His clueless friends teased him for getting so pale. That was when Lloyd figured that something was wrong, that he had to do something. But more than that, he wanted to burp.

That was why I looked for a fizzy drink.

He heard that drinking a fizzy drink wasn't a good way to soothe an upset stomach. It could worsen the pain. But Lloyd didn't know this back then. All he wanted was to chug down a drink and let out an almighty burp to relieve his stomach. And as luck would have it, he found a cider in his friend's bag. Popping the lid of the sixteen-ounce bottle, Lloyd guzzled the drink, only to sputter it out.

It was soju.

Soju in a cider bottle. It was one of the contraband goods his friend trafficked away from the teacher's radar. It was too late by the time Lloyd realized. Though he spat the alcohol out, he had taken several sips already. Soju on top of the upset stomach. His first ever drinking. From then on, he felt a clawing sense of nausea in his stomach, as if a nuclear bomb had been dropped there. Lloyd vomited and retched through the night, feeling dizzy and groggy. Thus, the mere recollection of his first-ever school trip brought that sense of despair back to his present self. But thankfully, his moment of

recollection didn’t last long, thanks to the question that interrupted his thoughts.

“So, the Kraken is acting up because it has an upset stomach?”

Lloyd was jostled out of his trance when his ears picked up the question, and he looked at the source. The mermaid queen was there. Deep furrows between her brows. And she was staring at Lloyd with a grim and flustered gaze.

“Oh, that’s right,” nodded Lloyd, and it was then he refocused on his present situation. The Kraken had gone rampant. The Mermaid Corps stood by to lay a forcible attack on it. He had been anxious about the possible damages to the jewel foundation. His realization that something was off about the monster. The octopus dry heaved and retched. It even rubbed its stomach with its legs. These were the typical behaviors of a human with an upset stomach.

Once it became clear to Lloyd, he had hurriedly swam to the queen’s and shouted at the latter, who was about to order the merpeople to charge forward. He begged her to wait as the Kraken might be in trouble. They needed to find a solution other than having an armed fight. He stopped her and managed to hold off the attack for some time.

“An upset stomach?” the queen inquired as she stared gravely at Lloyd. “That means it is suffering from indigestion. Is this true?”

“It appears so, indeed,” Lloyd said.

“What is your proof of that?” she demanded.

“I have been watching the Kraken retch while it roared. I also spotted it dry heaving a few times. Furthermore, look at how it rubs its stomach with its legs while writhing and then retches again. This seems like a typical case of an upset stomach, don’t you think?”

“Hmm... I do not know. We don’t get upset stomachs.” The queen pumped her pecs each. “Can you not relieve them with muscular strength?”

“Um,” Lloyd hesitated, “The stomach muscles are involuntary and can’t be moved at will.”

“Who cares?” puffed the queen. “All you need to do is to press your stomach with your abs.”

Lloyd was utterly speechless.

Might as well say that you can use your brain by flexing the muscles on your scalp!

However, Lloyd couldn’t voice his thoughts out loud. It wasn’t really because he was scared of getting punched. Rather, he was rather afraid to see her brazenly answer that it could be done. Her answer would surely make anatomists foam at their mouths. Lloyd shook off his dismay by shaking his head.

“No, haah, anyway,” insisted Lloyd, “I believe this is a case of an upset stomach from what I see. You may not be familiar with it, but humans like us get an upset stomach from time to time.”

“Do you think that the Kraken has an upset stomach based on your experiences?” considered the queen gravely.

“Indeed, that’s correct.”

“Hmm. Is that so?” Thankfully, it appeared that the queen, though still half in doubt, was considering Lloyd’s opinion. This was a golden opportunity, but her doubts could quickly turn into full-blown suspicion.

Sensing it, Lloyd immediately said, “Yes, so it will be better to confirm this possibility first.”

“Check it?”

“Yes. You must confirm first before trying to respond.”

“But how do we confirm it? Do you have a plan in mind?”

“I do.” Lloyd nodded. Surely, there was. He had thought of one before he desperately swam to stop the queen’s order to charge forward. “Is there a food or snack the Kraken likes?”

“Hm, there is. But why do you ask?”

“If you give me that information, you will be able to confirm what is happening.”

“How?” The queen was confused as to where Lloyd was getting at.

“If it does not have an upset stomach, it will still react violently to your snack.”

“And what if it has an upset stomach?” Her gaze grew icy.

Lloyd replied confidently, “At first, it will stop and show interest in your snack as usual. But soon, it will retch and turn away, only to throw another fit.”

“Then,” summarized the queen, “The key is whether it goes on rampant right away or after showing initial interest. Am I right?”

“Yes, that is a precise summary,” conceded Lloyd with a smile.

“Great. Let us do it.”

“Do you plan on trying it yourself, my queen?”

“Who else will do it if not me?” The queen looked down at Lloyd with a relaxed smile unique to the powerful. “Who can get close to the savage Kraken? Me. Who can swim the fastest in this sea and dolphin-kick without being swept away by the current? Me. Lastly, who can best endure the blows from the Kraken? Me.”

The queen pounded her chest muscles as if her answer was obvious. “Should I send out a frail merperson who is weaker than me instead? One of my vulnerable people? Not in a thousand years. I must step forward for a

matter like this. That is the responsibility and duty of someone on the throne.”

“Oh? Okay...”

“Or did you mean to test it out yourself?”

“No.” Lloyd blurted at lightning speed. Thankfully, it didn’t look like she thought about sending him there, for she merely chuckled. And then something came out of her pocket.

Noticing that it was a shiny light green marble, Lloyd asked curiously, “What is that?”

“A marine diamond,” replied the queen, her voice completely relaxed.

“I have never heard of it before.”

“If you take a regular diamond to the deepest part of the sea and squeeze in with all your strength for ten days in that terrifying water pressure, it becomes this unique jewel. Even I can only make a few stones a year. That is how exhausting the process is.”

“Th-Then it must be extremely expensive,” commented Lloyd, gulping as he spoke.

“That’s right. It probably is one of the most expensive stones in the world. That is why the Kraken loves it so much.”

“...” Lloyd almost told her that he’d be her Kraken instead of that gigantic octopus head. That was how marvelous the marine diamond was.

“Then I will go confirm what is happening. Everyone! Standby!”

The queen then swam toward the Kraken as it continued throwing a fit.

“...”

Was it in great pain and discomfort? Was the human right about it having an upset stomach? The queen felt apologetic.

If the human is right, then it only means that I, who have spent my entire life by your side, had a harder time understanding you than that mere man.

The queen wondered if she had gotten arrogant as she was always with the Kraken and became used to its presence. Had she failed to notice the agony it was in that even strangers could easily see? What if, out of her ignorance, she tried to suppress her precious friend by force? The queen swam over to the Kraken's side, reflecting on her actions.

"Kru-rururung!"

The Kraken let out a cry, which was now more sorrowful when it felt her near. Their eyes met. She instantly knew.

The Kraken is sorry for all this.

The Kraken's gaze was filled with remorse. At the same time, it was filled with pain and dismay.

Is what the human said really correct?

Biting her bottom lip, she inched closer to the Kraken and held out her palm with the marine diamond on top.

"Kraken? Do you want this? This is your favorite snack," the queen carefully said.

Thump! Thump! She hoped that the human would be right. She prayed that her friend would react the way the human said it would. She yearned direly in her heart. Some seconds later, the Kraken froze.

"Krung?" *Sniff! Sniff! Sniff!* The octopus stopped its violent fit and brought its head closer to the diamond before smelling it. Some seconds later...

"Krung! Kruru... Blargh! Krung!"

It violently retched, even spitting out a bit of stomach acid. And then it resumed its frenzy.

Whoosh! Because of its gigantic size, a small movement from the Kraken covered a wide distance.

"...!"

The queen closely avoided its leg by dolphin-kicking herself away from the spot. At last, she confirmed Lloyd's suspicion.

Ha... That human was right.

Even on her way here, she had been half in doubt. But upon confirming it herself, he was right. The Kraken showed initial interest in her offering but soon retched. It even burped and spat out stomach acid. The confirmation brought a sense of relief to her heart.

It's a relief. The Kraken had a reason for this behavior.

She couldn't have been more shocked at first. The Kraken had never caused such a commotion like the one today throughout the history of the Mermaid Kingdom. It was always a peaceful and gentle creature. So the entire situation threw her into a pit of confusion. That was until now, when she confirmed the reason for its strange behavior was an upset stomach. This joyful realization lifted the weight of confusion from her shoulders. Now, she only had to devise a solution for the issue, and a ray of hope that this unprecedented situation could be handled appeared. Now that the cause behind the incident was found, she wasn't as helpless anymore.

But...

As the queen fiercely swam away from the Kraken, sadness came to her eyes.

I am sorry, my friend.

She had been ignorant of her friend's pain. Instead, in her dismay, she almost suppressed it with force. A twinge of guilt for not recognizing her

friend’s sadness and difficulty gripped her. Simultaneously, she resolved that she would never let the Kraken be in pain again. She was ready to care for and dispel all the suffering it was going through. There wouldn’t be any challenges or hurdles that could stop her from that goal. Come hell or water, she was ready to relieve the pain of her friend.

Whatever the cost is!

Several drops of tears flowed along the current that appeared as the muscular queen swam by. Hiding her reddened eyes, she came back and asked Lloyd, “You saw the Kraken’s reaction, didn’t you?”

“Yes, of course,” answered Lloyd with a nod. The queen now felt a swelling sense of confidence in this human, who used to be nothing but a frail and scrawny figure in her eyes. She used to even feel pity toward him for having to live with such a weak body. But now, it was different. She couldn’t consider him to be any more reliable. The smile on his face. The confident gaze in his eyes. It all exuded a sense of trustworthiness.

“Do you have a solution to relieve its upset stomach?”

“Very well, I do,” Lloyd answered right away as if he had been waiting for her to ask.

The queen’s face lit up, and she thought to herself that he indeed had a plan. Everything was all good. She didn’t have anything to worry about from now on. Her precious friend wouldn’t be in pain anymore, and nothing would ever hurt it again. She was relieved. Confident. At that moment, she heard Lloyd casually state the solution he thought of.

“The best thing to do when you have an upset stomach is to mercilessly prick your fingertip to let the blood out!”

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Chapter 270: How to Treat an Upset Stomach (2)

“The best thing to do when you have an upset stomach is to mercilessly prick your fingertip to let the blood out!”

“...”

Bubble... A current of cold water swooshed past Lloyd and Queen Kiakora, its bubbles awkwardly drifting upward. The queen burst out laughing.

“Ha!” Dismay came over her. What did she just hear? But her ears were fine. What she just heard was utterly unbelievable. “Prick... a finger?” stammered the queen.

“Yes.” Lloyd confidently nodded. “The thing is, when you’re having an upset stomach, you’ve got to tie your finger and prick it with a needle!”

“And with a needle?!” The queen looked at her finger in greater confusion. “Fingers? I should prick them?”

“Yes,” answered Lloyd casually.

“Will any finger do?”

“No.” Lloyd shook his head. Pointing to the tip of his finger, he gravely said, “Do you see here? This is where the root is. Stab it! Give a prick! Then...”

“Then what?”

“You will see blood. Dark blood.”

“And after that?” Her voice was still filled with doubt.

“Remove the thread from your fingers and rub the back. That will cause it to burp.”

“But the Kraken already burped earlier-”

“It’s different,” Lloyd politely explained. “How do I say it? It’s this deep burp that comes from within.”

Gaping at Lloyd, Queen Kiakora seriously deliberated whether this human being was a quack from the land or a malicious imposter. But she soon shook her head, pushing her bad thoughts away.

No. He was the only one who knew that indigestion was the reason behind this mess.

On top of that, this was coming from a guy who had experience with this matter. The queen decided to believe in him a little more. She would remain skeptical but hear him out. Having decided, she asked, “Okay, let us say that the upset stomach will be gone by... pricking one of its fingers with a needle. But we are talking about the Kraken here. It does not have any hands. Do you plan to prick the ends of its legs?”

“Yes.” Lloyd grinned and continued to speak. “In all honesty, needling your hand in the case of an upset stomach isn’t a medically proven practice. It is just a home remedy, or perhaps, a treatment that triggers the placebo effect.”

“What is the placebo effect?”

“It’s when a treatment doesn’t have any medical effectiveness but rather affects the mind. You psychologically believe something works, and your condition gets healed because of that positive mindset,” explained Lloyd.

“Hold on. Then...”

“That’s right,” Lloyd finished her sentence. “Your Majesty should inform the Kraken beforehand about the effects of needling its legs in the most positive and confident manner possible.”

“So,” summarized the queen. “We need to prick the tips of its legs and hope the placebo effect will help.”

“That is correct.” Lloyd was relieved. The queen seemed to follow exactly what he instructed.

She is out of options, probably.

Since the merpeople were said to never get an upset stomach, Lloyd assumed that they wouldn’t know how painful it was to have an upset stomach.

And they won’t know that refreshing feeling you get in your stomach as it settles when you prick your finger.

Countless people dismissed this fingertip needling as a placebo effect. A host of media outlets and doctors on TV reiterated that it has no actual benefits. But there were quite a number of people in South Korea who experienced its effect, and Lloyd was one of them.

It works for sure. I experienced it myself.

On the first night of his high school trip, the night he accidentally took a swig of soju to relieve his stomach, Lloyd spent the whole night rushing to the bathroom and retching. Unable to ignore him, his friends reported him to their teacher, and even when she recognized the alcoholic smell, she showed a surprising reaction. Instead of lashing out at his friends, she went down to the lobby and brought a thread and needle to prick Lloyd’s finger.

Actually, I had no idea what she was going to do even as she tied up my finger. I thought it was a useless treatment. But it turned out to be effective.

Dark blood streamed out from his finger, and as she loosened the thread, she stroked his back. Then came the deepest and most refreshing burp he ever experienced. At the same time, the big lump in his stomach dissipated. It was a feeling that Lloyd could not forget, even to this day.

So, it might work this time too. No, it has to work.

What would happen if the Kraken commotion continued until it ended in an armed battle with the Mermaid Corps? There was a high chance the jewel

lot would be destroyed. Lloyd wished to avoid such mishaps from happening at all costs. Reminding himself of this, he suggested, “To be honest, I am unsure as to which leg we must prick. So, I say we prick them all.”

“All? All eight of them?”

“Yes,” stressed Lloyd, “You will have to tie up all of its eight legs and prick them at the same time when you see my signal.”

“Um...” Queen Kiakora faltered.

“It won’t die. And it’s not like something terrible will happen. Its upset stomach will be much more agonizing and painful than a couple of pricks.”

“Tsk. Fine. Let us give it a try.” Eventually, she conceded to his plan.

Still, his method will be better than suppressing the Kraken.

It’d be the case both for the Kraken and the merpeople. The queen summoned the generals under her command and quickly relayed the operation plan.

“That is all. Like I said, divide yourselves into seventeen units when you start to move. Am I clear?”

“Yes, my queen.”

“However, never put yourselves at risk or push yourselves too hard. When you sense danger, you must command your merpeople to retreat. Got it?”

“Your wish is my command.”

The generals nodded before returning to their respective units. From that moment, the merpeople busily kickstarted their operation. The first one to swim was the queen, who hurtled toward the Kraken as she yelled that help was on the way and endured the treatment even if it was painful. That it would prick for a bit, but it’s all for its sake. She drew the octopus’s

attention as she yelled aloud. Meanwhile, the Mermaid Corps jumped into action.

Beep! Beep! A high-frequency sound reminiscent of a whistle blow rang aloud. It was a signal used among the units to communicate with one another. The Corps was subdivided into seventeen units. Up, down, left, and right. East, west, south, and north. The operation took place as each unit moved in several different directions.

“Sisters! Aim for the ends of its legs!”

“Remember! Tie up the tip!”

“Use your hair!”

“Tighten the knot!”

The merpeople plucked a handful of hair before tying and connecting to form eight hair ropes that stretched hundreds of feet. The eight units in charge of the rope swam closer toward the legs of the Kraken.

“Grab tight!”

“Hold it!”

Hundreds of merpeople clutched the tip of the Kraken’s legs, each of them exerting a massive amount of strength to slow its movements. While this happened, the hair ropes were wrapped around the ends of its legs.

“Tie it!”

“Pull!” It formed a knot.

“Kru-rururung!” The Kraken writhed once more at the restrictive feeling. “Krung!”

Like a child struggling to not get his finger pricked, the Kraken roared ferociously and wielded all of its legs. But the merpeople didn’t just stay still and do nothing.

“Needle!” The queen’s command prompted the eight units in charge of the needle to advance. Their needle was the horn of the Gigatitan stored in the weaponry egg.

“Charge!”

Ten merpeople were assigned to each horn, and they swam in full force at a daunting speed. The horn of the Gigatitan glinted sharply and pricked eight legs of the sea monster.

Just then, the queen shouted, “Twist and pull out!”

They needed to give a clean prick but slightly twist the needle as they pulled out so more blood would come out.

Thwack! The giant needle that pierced 6.5 feet deep was pulled out after a twist, incising a slab of the Kraken’s skin. Given its humongous size, however, it wasn’t a serious cut. It was just a little sting.

“Krung!”

The Kraken pulled its legs close to its body, taken aback by the simultaneous stinging pain. The merpeople loosened the rope, and it started to bleed.

Splash! Supposedly, the Kraken’s blood was blue. But now, its color was...

“It’s murky and dark!” One of the merpeople shouted. Every merperson quickly drew back as they observed the Kraken, which was violently wielding its legs. The color of the blood spilling out of them was darker than usual. The sight brought an eruption of cheer from the merpeople.

“We succeeded!”

The operation worked. It was just as the land human said, dark blood would come out of the Kraken after nicking the tips of its legs.

I never thought such an outrageous solution would work.

But the operation was yet to be finished. The Kraken still needed to burp.

Knowing this well, the queen adamantly yelled, “Unit seventeen!”

At her call, unit seventeen instantly took action. They brought over 30 emperor whales that they had hurriedly gathered from a nearby sea.

“Approach!”

The whales swam at the guidance of the merpeople, and though they were a little scared, they approached the Kraken from behind since the request was coming from the merpeople. The whales then clung to the Kraken’s skin. Their bodies, which were often mistaken by humans as the head of an octopus, drew closer to the octopus.

“Rub!”

They diligently rubbed the Kraken with their entire body, caressing its belly and back. The octopus's face relaxed a little.

“K-Krurung...”

Its voice softened, and its eyes relaxed when...

Buuuuurp! The Kraken let out a deep and intense burp that echoed through the area. The clear, ringing sound coming from the orchestra that was its intestinal villi seemed to spread across the entire world.

“It’s over...”

The queen clenched her fists. The plan actually worked. The echoing burp wouldn’t have come out otherwise. The Kraken wouldn’t look as relaxed otherwise.

We did it.

The Kraken should feel more comfortable now. So, the only thing left for them was to comfort their friend and gather up the scattered eggs to rebuild the city. The bottled-up tension finally vanished in the queen’s heart. And

beaming brightly, she went back to Lloyd to compliment his great contribution. But she found him still grimacing.

This isn't over yet. It didn't burp enough.

In contrast to the merpeople who were cheering and celebrating their success, Lloyd was frowning. There were deep wrinkles forming between his brows. His gaze on the Kraken was grave. The reason was simple.

Its stomach is still upset.

The merpeople wouldn't know, but he knew because he had used his surveying skill on the monster. He was able to take a look sixteen feet deep into its body, although the Kraken was so large that he still couldn't get past its thick, leathery skin. Nonetheless, Lloyd still observed the octopus's skin movement and blood flow. That was how he knew.

Ever since it's been suffering from an upset stomach, I noticed a mild, irregular convulsion in its skin. And it's still happening right now. The burping stopped the convulsions for a bit, but it's starting again.

Lloyd instantly knew. The operation was yet to be finished.

It worked, sure. But the plan was only about 98% successful.

Lloyd estimated that the leg needling and burping weren't enough to relieve the Kraken's pain due to how severe its indigestion was. Lloyd, thus, decided to take a drastic measure.

Since the pricking and the burping didn't work, I'm left with no other choice. I need to make it vomit.

Time was running out, it seemed. The Kraken was close to being rampant once again. It would be too late by then. It was now or never. There was no time to inform or explain anything to the others. Sensing that, Lloyd immediately threw his hand into his pocket and brought Bangul out.

"Hey, Bangul," said Lloyd to Bangul, who was perched on his palm.

“Bangul?”

“I’m sorry, but I think you should use your volcanic explosion for us.”

“Bba-bangul?”

“Over there. With me on your back. Do you think you can do it?”

“Bangul!” Bangul earnestly nodded, so Lloyd fed her red sunflower seeds and hopped on her back once she grew larger. Bangul began gulping the water and wagged her tail.

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

Jingle! Jingle! Her warning rattle rang aloud in the water, and right after that, she raised her tail, discharging a massive explosion. “Bangul!”

Boooom! Volcanic explosion with massive strength. The force sent Bangul away like a rocket, and Lloyd, too, experienced the same thing as he was on her back.

“Argh...!

A terrible current of water hit his face and body. He ducked down as low as he could see and checked his target. His gaze focused on the Kraken, and he zoomed in on the middle of its forehead, which he learned from the surveying skill was the connecting point between its head and stomach. Lloyd pointed toward its direction.

“Hey, Bangul!”

“Bangul!”

“Do you see where I’m pointing at?! Toward the middle part of its forehead! One more time!” shrieked Lloyd as the adrenaline started to pump in him.

“Bba-bangul!”

Boooom! Two volcanic explosions consecutively erupted in the water!

"...!"

Lloyd was thrown at a greater speed, and the water current hit him much harsher. But Lloyd didn't lose his focus. At the final moment, he reversed his shovel, leaped from Bangul's back, and fired the triple manablast.

Kaboom! The third explosion propelled him farther, and he was now a torpedo flying toward the forehead of the Kraken. With that immense speed, he rammed right into its forehead.

Thwack! Lloyd managed to lay an attack right at his desired target, the Kraken's soft and thick forehead. Anatomically, it was the point that adjoins its head and stomach. The human equivalent of it would be the pit of one's stomach. There. That was where the third rocket propulsion landed. The effect of it was impressive.

Blergh! The Kraken convulsed and vomited something in a flash.

Retch! A big lump of emerald sculpture, which resonated at the same frequency as the Jewel of Truth, emerged.

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Chapter 271: The Aotearoa's Blueprint (1)

Crash! Lloyd's world quaked as the impact immediately threw him into a dizzy stagger. He couldn't tell if he was underwater, on top of land, or up in the sky. Everything was a blur. Lloyd curled up amid the devastating impact, chaos, and confusion. And he behaved just like the first time he let himself get blackout drunk after a night of binge-drinking at his college orientation.

Blergh! He dry-heaved with his empty stomach. It wasn't a surprising response from him.

Ughh... I almost passed out.

Lloyd looked up after just barely being able to suppress his mild concussion and dizzying nausea. He saw a giant silhouette right in front of him. No, it was a mountain, only that it was covered with a thick outer skin instead of rocks, stones, and soil. Its body diameter extended over several miles long and was as vast as Mount Everest. It was the Kraken, the giant octopus, convulsing before Lloyd's eyes and retching like Lloyd was a moment ago.

"Krung! Blergh!"

When he saw the Kraken, a thought crossed his mind.

I've gone mad. Completely mad.

No matter how critical the situation was earlier, he still couldn't believe he rammed into this massive creature. Lloyd was almost certain that he was a madman.

But still, I had my reasons for trying. For one, its skin isn't hard.

Lloyd recalled the trail of events that took place earlier. The operation ended in success after the merpeople pricked all eight of the octopus's giant legs in almost one try and caused dark blood to gush out of them. In response, the Kraken gave a deep and resounding burp.

But the burp wasn't enough. It was about two percent short of what it needed to be.

That was the thing with a sudden, acute upset stomach. It was tenacious. You could take digestive medicine, prick your finger, and then have your back smacked by your mom after she finds out your test scores. Or, you could do a handstand and bow down to your boss after sending a wrong text to them. But it never, ever went away.

The Kraken was in that exact state.

It wasn't enough to prick the Kraken's legs and make it burp. The effect of this plan was only temporary. Lloyd, thus, took action the moment he realized what was happening. Since he had no time to waste, he used the power of two consecutive volcanic explosions from Bangul and his triple manablast, catapulting the attacks between the Kraken's brows. In comparison, this was the same area as the upper abdomen for humans. In other words, what Lloyd did was equivalent to throwing an almighty punch to someone's upper abdomen. And the punch now left the Kraken squirming and emptying everything in its stomach.

Great! See? That's what I'm talking about! Vomiting is the best treatment for an acute case of an upset stomach if pricking your finger doesn't work.

Even though forced vomiting could cause reflux esophagitis, it was a last-ditch effort to treat an upset stomach when nothing else worked. It had to be done even when stomach acid could damage a patient's esophagus as well as teeth and take a serious toll on their stomach.

That was the reason why Lloyd had gone on with it. But prior to doing so, he first scanned the Kraken's upper abdomen to guarantee his own safety and examine how sturdy and firm the area was. He even activated his simulation skill afterward. In other words, Lloyd boldly threw himself into action only after his simulation assured him no serious damage would be done to him. But, of course, Lloyd was not left entirely unharmed.

Argh. I feel nauseous.

Was it a mild concussion? His dizziness and nausea continued to assault him. However, soon, a reward that would easily make up for his pain emerged in front of his eyes.

Ding Dong!

[You have provided excellent treatment for the Kraken's upset stomach with your sharp situational awareness, sound judgment and courageous actions.]

[For this, the treated Kraken and merpeople praise you, and they are extremely impressed by you.]

[You have earned a new title.]

Ohh?!

It was a message Lloyd would never get tired of seeing. Lloyd determined that this issue had been successfully resolved before focusing on his new title and relishing his reward.

[A new title <Upper abdomen! Upper abdomen! Upper abdomen!> has been created.]

[Upper abdomen! Upper abdomen! Upper abdomen!!]

[Title Level: Maritime legend]

[Mother, my stomach feels sick.

Is that so? Give me your stomach, my dear.

But Mother, why?

Your stomach will feel better after a hit.

I feel that it will not just make me comfortable but put me in a permanent state of sleep.

It’s all right, baby. Do not be afraid.

But still, I’m scared it will hurt. I’m scared.

Tsk, tsk. Learn from the Kraken.

What about the Kraken?

It was hit in the stomach and is still well alive.

But still, it doesn’t mean that getting hit won’t hurt.

Then do you want to keep having an upset stomach?

Um... No.

So, bring over your stomach to me.

But, mother! I am scared!

It’s all right, baby. How hard could I possibly even hit, my dear?

Waa... It’s the punch of... Love!

Wham.]

[Compliment Effect: You have resolved the Kraken’s indigestion in one try. The Kraken and thousands of members of the Mermaid Corps clearly witnessed this. For this, your heroic feat will spread throughout all the seas in the world, and getting hit in the upper abdomen will become the go-to method among marine creatures to treat indigestion. Moreover, you have acquired <Underwater Breathing> and <Upper Abdomen Jab>. The former skill allows you to freely breathe underwater, and the latter skill enables you to empty anyone’s stomach in the water with just one jab.]

[Title Region: Any terrain that has a water level of above 20 inches, which includes seas, rivers, lakes, and bathtubs.]

[Active Period of Title: 3,000 Years.]

[A title's powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region for which the compliment was given. Moreover, the time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 5]

[Current CP: 1,312]

Nice. Super nice.

Lloyd clenched his fists. The title was awesome, just like the others. And it was a confirmation that the Kraken was no longer suffering from an upset stomach. The optional skills he was rewarded were extremely useful too.

Underwater breathing? This means I can freely breathe three-foot below the water without this necklace the merpeople gave me. Of course, the water pressure and temperature will be a different story. But I won't drown, at least. And as for the upper abdomen jab... Um, I suppose it's a useful skill to empty the stomach of someone I don't like.

In any case, Lloyd was able to acquire two ever-so-useful powers.

Okay, I should back off now.

A thought crossed Lloyd's mind that he might face a terrible ending if he hovered around any longer. It was because of the Kraken.

I gave a pretty hard punch to this monster. I mean, it even vomited.

Only the heavens knew what kind of payback the Kraken would unleash against Lloyd in its anger. If it came charging at Lloyd with its body that was the size of Mount Everest, he wasn't confident he could handle that honestly. He wondered if even Javier, who was a grandmaster, could block the octopus. Just then...

Ding Dong!

Lloyd was sneakily watching the Kraken's movement for any chance to escape when a clear ringing noise rang again.

Hmm?

At first, he wasn't sure what he was hearing, so he reflexively moved his gaze to find a set of unexpected messages floating above.

[The Kraken has opened its heart to you.]

[It took you as the true friend for treating its indigestion.]

[The Kraken now considers you as a friend on equal footing.]

[You can now increase your likeability through the Kraken and acquire RP.]

[50 RP has been rewarded for forming a new connection with another creature.]

[Current RP: 2,532]

[Your likeability with the Kraken has increased by 11 points.]

[Current RP with the Kraken: +11]

[You have earned 33 RP by improving your relationship with a character.]

[Current RP: 2,565]

Damn.

His likeability with the Kraken? Lloyd never thought this would be possible. Just then…

"Krung! Krurung!"

The Kraken roared in almighty ferocity under Lloyd's nose, rolling its eyes over to his side. Its eyeballs, Lloyd thought, were scarily huge.

"..."

Have you ever received the gaze of football-field-sized eyeballs? For a second, Lloyd was glad that he could now give a confident "yes" to the question, should it appear in a job interview. If the interviewer further asked what it felt like, then he'd say, "I wet myself within a second." That was how overwhelming this situation was. But could it be that the Kraken recognized Lloyd's feelings? It extended, very carefully and slowly, a leg in his direction.

"..."

Lloyd almost screamed, "I'm sorry! I won't eat octopus legs anymore!" as a giant shadow cast over his head. The second before he gave way to pressure and burst into an inconsequential gibberish, an unexpected object stuck to one of the Kraken's suckers caught his eyes.

A sculpture?

It was an approximately ten-foot-long seahorse sculpture made of glimmering emerald. The sculpture was vibrating terribly, much like a phone buzzing from a misplaced call on a lazy Sunday morning.

That vibration feels familiar. Why is that?

Lloyd thought to himself as he looked at the sculpture.

The foundation site vibrated exactly like that when Mr. Rotorua touched the starfish symbol. And the surrounding seawater resonated with the vibration.

The sculpture appeared to be vibrating similarly to the resonation a while ago. No, its intensity and pattern were almost the same. A theory popped into Lloyd's head.

Wait a minute!

Lloyd immediately asked the Kraken, “Did you vomit this out?”

“Krung!” The Kraken roared.

“Is your stomach all right now that you spat this out?” Lloyd followed up with another question.

“Krurung!” The Kraken nodded, having understood Lloyd’s words. Then it added, “Krurung! Krung! Krurung! Krung!”

The Kraken was saying that it had accidentally engulfed the sculpture about 300 years ago. It was an accidental mistake that occurred when it curiously discovered something glinting in the deep sea. And it had forgotten that this happened as nothing particular took place afterward. Of course, Lloyd didn’t understand any of the things the Kraken was saying. But he was able to make out the meaning behind the octopus's words through its actions.

So, it felt fine after spitting out the sculpture... That’s it. The sculpture was vibrating inside the Kraken, which upset its stomach. That was the cause behind its sudden upset stomach.

The blow sent to its upper abdomen forced the sculpture out, which relieved its stomach pain.

Plus, the vibration in the sculpture is the same as the one from the foundation site. The pattern and the intensity. That could only mean one thing...

The object had much to do with the Jewel of Truth. Convinced, Lloyd asked, “Um, are you showing me this... because you’re giving it to me?”

“Krung!” When the answer came right away, Lloyd immediately snatched the sculpture before the Kraken changed its mind.

Pop! Bzzzt! The sculpture left the sticky sucker and landed in his embrace.

Whew...

Lloyd wondered if this was what it felt like to carry a 10-foot mobile phone put on the highest vibration setting. He struggled to fight the dizziness and nausea surging from his stomach and hurriedly swam his way back to the foundation site.

If my guess is correct, this sculpture should be part of the site of the jewel.

So, it should be placed in its rightful place. Then a secret of some sort had to be revealed. From then on, Lloyd tirelessly swam and left the merpeople gathering up to check on the Kraken. Javier and Rotorua soon joined Lloyd, and all of them went back to the jewel's site. As they approached, the vibration in the sculpture amplified. *Bzzzzzz!!!*

Ack!!

The concussion was already making him nauseous and dizzy, and the sculpture's vibration was making it all feel worse for him. Lloyd swallowed the bile that kept rising above his throat.

From his side, Javier worryingly asked, "Are you all right, Young Master?"

"Do I look okay in your eyes?" Lloyd's voice dripped with annoyance and exhaustion.

Javier ignored Lloyd's unwelcoming tone as he replied. "Um, you seem fine and not fine at the same time."

"What is that supposed to mean?" snapped Lloyd, frowning.

"It means that I am worried and amused at the same time."

"..."

"Give me your back, please," Javier, who was gloating with his eyes, reached out and placed his hand on Lloyd's back. Is he using the Asrahan Core Technique? Lloyd thought to himself as he felt a warm influx of mana, which traveled through his skin, muscle, spine, nerves, and blood vessels, slowly circling around his whole body until it flowed out to Javier's palm

through his back. The mana felt like a warm breath of air on a painful injury. Soon, his dizziness and nausea completely disappeared.

“You should feel better now, Master Lloyd. Your complexion has improved.” Javier grinned. And he added, “Your face is mediocre to begin with, so you should at least have a healthy complexion.”

“Sure... I’m tearing up at your kindness,” replied Lloyd.

“Not at all.”

“Haah. You treated my body, but you’re killing my spirit. It feels great for you, right?”

“Yes, indeed.”

“The heck. You aren’t even trying to deny it.” Lloyd shot a flustered look at Javier.

Javier’s smile grew bigger. “It is enjoyable to watch your flustered expression that appears in moments like this.”

“...”

“You do not have to compensate me for treating you. You amused me well enough.”

“Ha. Hahaha.” Lloyd burst out in laughter. Still, he figured that this was Javier’s way of showing concern.

Anyhow, time to get back to business.

Lloyd then focused on the sculpture in his embrace.

Bzzzzz!! The vibration was much stronger now, and he focused his attention on its intensity.

On my way here, the vibration was consistent in its intensity, but it changed a little now.

The vibration intensity was changing depending on his direction around the jewel lot. This indicated only one thing.

The vibration is getting stronger as we get closer to the spot it should be placed at.

From that moment, Lloyd directed his steps following the vibration of the sculpture, approaching confidently and wading through the current until he found the right location.

This is the spot.

About 20 yards south of the jewel's foundation site, there was a hole that was about 27 inches in diameter. The sculpture's stylobate was shaped exactly like the hole.

Could this be the entrance to the jewel?

It appeared so. Thinking so, Lloyd put down the sculpture.

Swoosh! The bottom smoothly went into the hole, instantly fading the vibration of the jewel and foundation to a stop. From that moment onward...

Crackle...! The sculpture was covered with a glistening light that dizzyingly reflected inside its emerald interior. The light streamed out from the eyes and sketched a three-dimensional painting of light in the water. Elegant lines and surfaces. An elaborate dance of light. Finally, the blueprint of the Jewel of Truth emerged, and Lloyd murmured to himself when he realized it looked surprisingly familiar.

What is that? A pyramid? The Tomb of the General?

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Chapter 272: The Aotearoa's Blueprint (2)

Pyramid. It was a structure that everyone thought of when hearing about ancient Egypt. It was also the first structure everyone thought of when asked to name an ancient relic. But the pyramid wasn't exclusive to Egypt. There were similar structures across the world, albeit in slightly different time periods.

This is because of the technological limitations at the time. Construction technology hadn't advanced far, and there was an absence of lightweight, strong materials like steel. As a result, buildings were made using rocks, which made them exponentially heavier the larger they were. But since there wasn't any effective technology to stabilize their weight, most buildings in ancient times naturally took the shape of a pyramid.

The pyramid-shaped buildings boasted a wide bottom and pointed top that was relatively narrow and light. These tapered structures had a wide and heavy bottom while their upper portion was narrow and light. This allowed their center of gravity to be extremely low and stable because of the balanced distribution of their substantial weight. As such, pyramids, despite their humongous size, managed to stand tall even after all these years.

Thanks to it, most pyramid structures have been fairly well preserved in several parts of the world. To name a few, there's the Chichén Itzá of Mexico which was built during the Maya civilization, the Aztec pyramid with the stairs, the Ziggurat of Ur, and the Pyramids of Güímar in the Canary Islands of Spain. The tombs of ancient Chinese emperors are also another example. We even have one in South Korea as well. The Tomb of the General.

The Tomb of the General was the most developed stone mound tomb of the Goguryeo Kingdom in ancient times. It was possible that some would accuse him of being a jingoist for calling this structure a pyramid. But clearly and evidently, without an inkling of doubt, the Tomb of the General was some sort of pyramid.

Though, of course, there's a great difference in size between the Egyptian pyramid and the Tomb of the General.

But why did he think of the Tomb of the General now out of all times? Why did his brain associate it with the sight in front of him, which was the blueprint for the Jewel of Truth?

How could I not? The two look very similar.

Lloyd lifted his gaze, taking in the jazzy hologram video of the emerald sculpture he had gone on a great length to place into its rightful place. The video was the blueprint of the Jewel of Truth, but it felt familiar. From any perspective he looked, it was an appropriate mixture of the Tomb of the General and the Pyramid of Egypt.

Kudos to me for joining the traditional architecture club back in college.

Thanks to his club, Lloyd could specifically identify these sorts of historical architectural styles.

Strong rocks are laid out as the foundation. As for the stylobate, is that granite? The top is composed of seven flights of stairs. I also think I see some holding stones. There are even a few raised areas to prevent the bottom of the structure from getting crushed by the weight coming down. Plus, the inner stone chamber is roofed with a ceiling where the stones are set in parallel to each other. It's the typical stone chamber tomb. I guess the chamber isn't meant to hold a corpse but is where the magic circle is activated.

Lloyd's sharp eyes ran a thorough analysis of the blueprint, and the more he looked at it, the more it looked like the Tomb of the General from the Goguryeo time period. Just then, the hologram changed its shape. *Crackle...!*

Hmm?

Countless dots appeared around the hologram blueprint, most of them as small as a speck of dust or a fruit fly. Upon a closer look, Lloyd noticed that

they weren’t dots.

Humans? Merpeople? Orcs?

A countless number of humans and merpeople were fighting, their forces clashing. The orc warriors and elf archers tussled with each other, and the giants ran amok as they swept the surrounding area.

It’s a war.

But this one was different from any ordinary war. It resembled Hell, where hundreds and thousands of forces of different races charged forward to kill each other. Lloyd recognized which war this was as soon as he saw it.

Mr. Rotorua said before that Jewel of Truth used to be the most powerful treasure and weapon during ancient times. Everyone sought to get their hands on it, and a war started. This is that war.

The hologram was playing before Lloyd’s very eyes, and every race was battling against each other in the war that ended the mythical age. Warriors were thrown into a bloody frenzy until a critical blow destroyed the Jewel of Truth. No one could know who the culprit was. Not a single one had the time or sense to notice what happened amidst the constant chaos. Eventually, the Jewel of Truth collapsed, toppling down the stairs and crumbling to pieces. The entire structure, aside from the foundation, was utterly destroyed and reduced to a war trophy.

Everyone is... taking the rubbles of the jewel.

Human knights, orc warriors, elf archers, and giant magicians... They were all competing with each other to collect the rubbles of the jewel as their trophy. That erupted into another conflict. Everyone was filled with tenacity and determination to get their hands on one more piece. The scene reminded Lloyd of a colony of ants assembling around a giant carcass. And with that, the video ended.

Crackle...! The dots, lines, and sides that beautifully hung in the air vanished. Now, there was only dark, murky seawater. Just then...

Ding dong.

A notification alarm dinged in his ears.

Hmm?

Lloyd wondered what the notification was about. Cocking his head, he read the messages starting to appear in front of his eyes.

[You have activated the “Guideline Sculpture to the Jewel of Truth.”]

[You have witnessed the destruction of the Jewel of the Truth from it.]

[In the process, you were able to closely observe the structure of the Jewel of Truth. This experience had a strong effect on your design skill.]

[The blueprint of the Jewel of Truth, the Aotearoa, has been registered in your design skill data.]

What?

Lloyd was taken aback. The Jewel of Truth, the Aotearoa, was registered as part of his design skill? This was something he never expected and was experiencing for the first time.

Until now, it was only possible to upload a blueprint for my design skill if I surveyed or designed one myself.

That was the way it was up to this point. Whether it was an empty piece of land or a building, Lloyd had to personally survey it in detail first before he could utilize its blueprint in his design space. He could only insert a blueprint in his virtual design space after going through the strenuous process of surveying the data of a building while straining his eyes the entire time. Another way to do so was to use all his focus and pull several all-nighters for the drudgery of designing a blueprint that was absolutely error-free. But right now...

Wow!

All he did was view a hologram video one time. And the message appeared to tell him that he could show the jewel blueprint in his design space.

Let's first check it out. The design.

Lloyd activated the skill at once, and the virtual design space visible and recognizable only to him appeared.

Bring out data. The Aotearoa's blueprint.

Will this really work? Lloyd gave it a try. The result came immediately.

[Fetching the "Aotearoa's Blueprint."]

Fwoosh! For a second, the design space brightened until it was marked with a complex array of dots, lines, and surfaces. The sturdy and wide foundation. The tapered top. The blueprint was the same as the Jewel of Truth he saw through the hologram video a moment ago.

This is real. Amazing.

Lloyd found himself clenching his fist. What appeared in his design space was more than a simple illustration.

Zoomed in like this, I can see that everything is included here. The measurements, materials, standard requirements, and compound method. It's all there.

Not just that. The stress distribution, weight, compressive force, axial force, bending moment, strain rate, temperature expansion coefficient, etc. Nearly all information required for the construction was marked there. In other words, it was so impeccable that he could start the reconstruction right away.

I've got enough laborers. The merpeople using the jjimjilbang can work at the reconstruction site. As for the materials and funds, I should ask for the queen. This so-called jewel is an amazing treasure from the mythical age that belongs to the merpeople. Since that's what I'm restoring, I'm sure the queen will provide me with a sufficient amount of aid.

Lloyd swelled with confidence as he thought about it. How he'd prepare and start the reconstruction. The challenges and the solutions. It was all assessed in his head in no time. Moreover, Lloyd was familiar with the structure of the jewel.

It's the Tomb of the General in a pyramid shape. I researched these structures back when I was still active in the club. I'll just need to combine the information from the documents I studied then with the blueprint. This is more than doable.

Thankfully, the pyramid structure wasn't very complex. Sure, precisely allocating the proper distribution of weight would be tricky, but this structure wasn't a highly difficult design to construct for a building.

It's a relief that the Tomb of the General was a part of my home country's history. And that it was built like a pyramid.

The Tomb of the General. Otherwise dubbed as the Pyramid of the East. Certainly, this one was poles apart from the Egyptian counterpart in terms of size. It was as different as a mammoth and a dog. But still, structure-wise, the difference wasn't noticeable. If the Egyptian pyramid was built in the middle of the ancient Korean peninsula...

People might have called it the Brobdingnagian, the giant Tomb of the General. Oh, since Gulliver wasn't written back then, maybe they'd just call it the giant.

Anyway, Lloyd felt that the construction would be smooth sailing, given his encounter with the Tomb of the General, when he noticed a tiny red message subtly floating in the bottom of the blueprint.

Hmm? What's this?

He read the message.

[The Aotearoa's Blueprint]

[Status: Construction not possible. You are missing key materials.]

[In the event you continue the construction without its key materials, the magic circle function, which is the crux of the Jewel of Truth, will be inoperable.]

“Ha... Right. Nothing is ever easy for me.” Lloyd felt growingly bitter after reading the message.

I’m missing key construction materials? The Jewel of Truth will only operate once I obtain them.

What if he built the jewel without its key materials for construction? It would result in a fake imitation that only looked like the Jewel of Truth.

That won’t do.

Lloyd shook his head. He wasn’t trying to restore a cultural artifact here. His goal was to activate the Jewel of Truth and prevent the restoration of destiny from occurring.

Hmm... So, where can I get my hands on these key materials?

Lloyd grumbled to himself as he observed the blueprint, thinking that the answer would be there. And he was right.

What are these areas that have been marked red?

Upon a closer look, some parts of the design were slightly off. Only a few select areas were marked in red.

Let’s see.

Lloyd poked one of the red areas as if he was clicking it. But nothing happened. No information whatsoever popped up.

Is it not meant to be clicked?

Dismayed, Lloyd decided to give every red spot a poke. He continued to poke when the one at the bottom of the design reacted with a click. It was the part about the holding stones of the Tomb of the General.

Ding dong.

[You have selected the first key material for construction, “tauranga.”]

[Do you wish to access information about tauranga?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it’s a yes!

Lloyd nodded earnestly. Just then...

Fwoosh! A new video emerged in front of him as if it was trying to intrude his vision or he was dreaming with his eyes open.

A video recording, maybe?

It looked like one. Lloyd focused on the video.

Boom! Baaang! A large human, no, a giant was landing onto a beach, and it was carrying twelve pieces of rocks in its embrace. Lloyd instantly recognized the rocks.

Those look like the key materials I just saw for the stylobate.

Lloyd recalled how the materials became a form of trophies once the jewel was destroyed. Tauranga, one of the key materials for construction, seemed to be one of them.

A giant, huh.

Lloyd squinted his eyes as he watched the video. In the video, the giant strode off while carrying the tauranga and built a city by the river, decorating its own palace with the same material. For the longest time, the giant ruled over humans as slaves until they waged war for independence. A long period of war, conflict, and struggle ensued. Eventually, the giant was killed.

Then came the world of humans. The leaders destroyed the giant's palace, and the Tauranga that decorated the palace was abandoned at the corner of the city. The city run by humans flourished for a long period of time until an enraged dragon took over the palace, causing the downfall of the imperial family and bringing in a new ruling house. Another palace was then constructed under the new regime with hard work and collaboration. At this point, twelve pieces of taurangas were brought back and used for the palace's foundation. There was no particular reason for this decision except that the aforementioned material was sleek, well-manicured, large, and sturdy. That was all.

In other words, the people under the new imperial regime were completely in the dark about the backstory of the twelve pieces of tauranga. That hardly was surprising. The war was something of the far distant past. It had become a mere legend from the mythical age. And just like that, the twelve pieces of tauranga were utilized to build a new palace. The video ended with the palace standing firm and tall.

"..."

Lloyd remained silent even well after the video ended. Instead of speaking out loud, he merely sighed. Why? Simple. The palace he just saw in the video? The palace that used the twelve taurangas was very familiar to him.

"Ha..." Lloyd sighed at length again. He couldn't help it. Then he grumbled to himself, "Out of all the places... Really? The place holding the tauranga had to be the palace of Queen Magentano. Ha!"

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Chapter 273: A Shameless Demand (1)

The City of Magenta. It was the political and economic hub of the Magentano Kingdom and boasted a long, rich history. Right after the great war of the mythical age, the Giant King Oculus erected a palace on this land and enslaved humans until they ousted the giant king by waging a war for independence. And the humans, having succeeded in attaining freedom, built their own kingdom for the first time in human history.

Their city was named “Taliah,” taken from their proud leader. Fast forward many years, the city enjoyed unhindered prosperity until one day, it went crashing down. It was all because of a greedy king who let a dragon take over the palace twice. After its miserable downfall, a new royal family took over the city, and naturally renamed the city “Magenta.” It was around that time the capital’s current landmark, the half-buried egg-shaped palace, was constructed. And today, inside the office of this egg-shaped palace, Queen Alicia Termina Magentano was sighing to herself as she slurped down a raw egg. *Crack. Slurp!*

“Whew...”

Queen Magentano wiped her wet hair with a towel, drinking the raw egg that her servant brought for her. Yet, the wrinkles on her face didn’t leave. It was because she was frustrated.

Truly, this is a mess.

Grimacing, she gazed at her office desk. There were messy piles of documents strewn all over it. They were the reports on the reconstruction of the Termina Garden wrecked by the Bone Dragon.

Thankfully, the reconstruction went well. It was completed without many issues. The final costs were quite high but not enough to put any burden on the kingdom’s finances. But the problem is...

They hadn’t redeemed all the damage that came from the Bone Dragon’s uproar. In particular, the intangible assets that couldn’t be seen by the eye

were what took the biggest hits.

The imperial family has suffered considerable damage to its reputation.

The grand garden had been constructed to flaunt the kingdom’s national prowess to the outside world, so the completion event similarly served the same purpose of exhibiting its grand results. In other words, it was a promotional showcase meant to announce to the world the authority of the House of Magentano. However, the event was a failure. A complete blunder. All because the bones of the dragon installed at the center of the garden moved against everyone’s expectations and ran amok. Everyone in attendance had to run for their lives, and the royal guards were left floundering around. The situation was so terrible that the queen herself had to grab her sword. That, however, wasn’t the worst part.

The worst part is... that we failed to capture the Bone Dragon.

Queen Magentano’s furrow deepened. That day, she failed to suppress the Bone Dragon. No, she did. To be more exact, she failed to announce that to the others, which tanked the reputation of the imperial family and made it an international laughingstock.

We were branded as the imperial family that adorned its capital with a grave threat. The *imperial family that failed to properly take down a dangerous enemy. The imperial family that shakily tried to defend itself...*

A glint of rage flashed in her eyes. Right after the Bone Dragon incident and when Lloyd and Javier left for Hell, she concentrated all her energy and attention on cleaning up the mess. She commemorated the victims, praised them as heroes and heroines, and accordingly compensated them. She poured an exorbitant amount of money into restoring the demolished garden. Meanwhile, she strove to revive the diminished authority of the imperial family, shedding light on the event by announcing that Lloyd Frontera and Javier Frontera bravely slayed the monster under her leadership. She even strove to clear her name by incorporating the accounts of the royal guard knights that witnessed the event. But the international community was...

They did not believe any of my words.

A bitter smile appeared on her face as she thought so. The world's doubtful reaction wasn't very surprising, however. After all, even if the Bone Dragon was indeed subdued, which was mainly possible due to Javier's contribution, there wasn't any evidence to back up her claim.

Why? Because Lloyd took the Bone Dragon as his subordinate.

If there was a way to exhibit the demolished pieces of the Bone Dragon to the world, things would have been better. But to her misfortune, no evidence was left. And so, the explanations the House of Magentano put out were received with global mockery. Everyone cast doubts on the authority of the House of Magentano, throwing various theories that the Bone Dragon could have simply fled because it got bored after having its share of fun destroying the place. That there should be evidence if the dragon was dead. But there wasn't any evidence. Moreover, the shadow of doubt didn't linger only among foreign countries.

The nobles of our kingdom started gossiping too.

Of course, she hardly worried much about them since her authority over the kingdom was strong and secure. Her legitimacy wasn't going to get impacted by this. Nonetheless, it wasn't exactly a pleasant development.

I must restore the damaged reputation of the imperial family.

Losing authority in an international setting meant several things. One was a reduction in diplomatic influence. From now on, she would experience inconveniences in international rows, clashes of interests, disputes, and negotiations, which all happened quite often. It was as if they were an injured lion getting looked down by a pack of hyenas.

But...

There didn't seem to be a striking solution to restore their international authority. This was the reason why she kept grimacing all day.

“Tsk.” She snatched a towel with annoyance and roughly shook the water off her hair. Despite doing so, her concern wasn’t shaken off.

“...”

She used to feel refreshed after snacking on a raw egg once she finished her sword training session and bath. But these days, this wasn’t the case anymore. Like a puzzle that couldn’t be solved, her unanswerable concern never left her head.

What about restoring the garden and holding another event? That wouldn’t be enough. A reconstruction celebration would change nothing. It would be better if a small-scale military conflict broke out on the border.

That would grant her the opportunity to shift the domestic and international attention elsewhere, and it could restore its diminished authority by showcasing its massive military power.

But that is not right.

The queen despised the idea of sending her innocent soldiers onto a battlefield just to regain the kingdom’s authority. The very purpose of getting it back in the first place was so she could better protect and care for these people of hers. As possible solutions got ticked off in her head one after another, her woes only grew.

After a long time, around the time her wet hair was half-dried, someone interrupted her thoughts. “Your Majesty, there is an individual who has requested a special audience with you.” It was the Lord Chamberlain who spoke from outside of her office.

“Audience with me?” Queen Magentano inquired. “Who is it?”

“It is Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera county, Your Majesty.”

The moment she heard his response, she squeezed her fist without realizing it. But why? Because the name was uncalled for? Because she felt a flash of

inexplicable expectation? But before she could find the answer for herself, she blurted out a response. “Let him in.”

“Your words are my command.” The Lord of Chamberlain’s footsteps grew distant. He must be bringing Lloyd to the office, the queen thought.

Queen Magentano propped her chin against her hands as she waited for the unexpected guest to emerge. “Haah.” She didn’t know why she was sighing. Was it from concern? Or surprise? Whatever it was, one thing was certain. She was glad to hear of Lloyd’s visit.

Lloyd Frontera.

A man who was extremely good at reading people. A subject of hers who came to possess greater power than her. A subject of hers, despite his capabilities, that she could strangely be at ease around.

It presumably should be because he and my political interests are aligned.

She was glad that Lloyd wasn’t an ambitious man. That he opted to live a normal life in the province. Apart from the gratitude in her heart, there was also wonder.

What is it that made him come here?

Queen Magentano smacked her lips, thinking to herself that Lloyd was not someone who would act without a clear purpose. And he was even more so not someone who would travel all the way here for nothing.

He only reaches out when there’s something he needs from me. Wait, is this his first time coming to visit me out of his own will?

The queen thought about it, and indeed, she was the one who always called for him first. He usually dragged himself to her with a terrible grimace and fidgeted the entire time, exuding his evident reluctance and annoyance to be summoned as if he was being forced there.

Tsk.

As such, his visiting of his own volition meant he wanted something from her. Otherwise, he'd have never willingly come to her.

What could it be that he wants?

What grand request does he have that prompted him to come here? She became very curious and expectant.

He is a sly man. If he wants something from me, he knows that it won't be free.

He likely had something valuable to negotiate with. Something very helpful to her, she thought.

He is a smart fellow.

In her current state, that is, where she spent every day worrying. It could only mean that Lloyd was ready to negotiate if he was coming here to make a request.

He must have identified what was worrying me and found a way to solve my worries. I'm sure he plans to capitalize on that to ask for help or assistance in return for his help.

It was a simple matter, come to think of it. And like that, Queen Magentano saw through the hidden meaning and intention behind Lloyd's unexpected visit. Around the time her hair was completely dried, she heard from the Lord Chamberlain again.

"Your Majesty, Lloyd Frontera has arrived," the Lord Chamberlain announced.

"Let him in."

The door opened. She saw Lloyd behind it.

"Hail to Her Majesty. I, Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera County, am honored to be in the audience of the rightful owner of this land."

Lloyd had his head down, revealing the back of his head. For a second, a sudden impulse to smack him instead of greeting him came over her. His head was chestnut-shaped, round, and circular, the kind that evoked the impulse to give it a whack.

"..."

Queen Magentano smothered the senseless impulse in her and focused on looking at Lloyd with a cold gaze. "It has been truly a long time, Lloyd Frontera."

"Yes, Your Majesty. I hope you have been in good health," remarked Lloyd, still bowing.

"Not so much. Unfortunately, since you did not heed my reminder." Her voice was cold, emotionless.

"Your Majesty...?" Lloyd looked up, dazed and befuddled.

Queen Magentano scoffed as she looked straight into his eyes. "You said it yourself before crossing the gate of Hell into the underworld. Do you not remember?"

Lloyd searched his memory. "Before going to Hell, then..."

"How you said that you could only come back to my side if you went to Hell through the method of your choice," reminded the queen.

"Oh..." gaped Lloyd.

"I told you then," went on Queen Magentano, her voice now sounding judgmental. "If you really care for me, make sure to come back to my side unharmed. Do you remember how you responded?"

"That... I will try my best, Your Majesty."

"How confident you sounded."

Lloyd’s face reddened as the memories came back to him. He knew where this was going.

“And yet, why did I have to hear about your pursuits from someone else after you came back from Hell?”

“...”

“I was suddenly given news about you one day. They said you, who disappeared during the Bone Dragon incident, suddenly appeared in your fiefdom.”

“...”

“I believe they said you visited Count Cremo afterward, is that right?”

“...”

“Indeed. I understand. Count Cremo is a big fan of yours.”

“...”

“Answer,” she ordered as the silence was starting to irritate her.

“Please kill me, Your Majesty.” Words broke out of him as he pleaded.

“Are you sure? Do you mean it?”

“N-no,” Lloyd stuttered with evident hesitation in his voice. “Your Majesty, it is not that.”

“Then?”

“I beg your forgiveness for saying these things, but due to several urgent and complicated situations, I could not simply abandon everything and come back to your side at once, Your Majesty.”

“Is that so?” She looked at Lloyd as she raised her brow.

“Yes, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd, stressing his voice. “All the while I was away from Your Majesty, my allegiance toward you never left for even a second.”

“Hmm...” mused Queen Magentano, “I have no way to tell if that is true.”

“That is-”

“However,” she interrupted, “It has been made very clear to me that you have unfortunately made your way first to Count Cremo, not me.”

“T-that’s...” Lloyd’s face turned crimson red.

“How did he welcome you? Did he open a grand ball? If not, that would have been truly problematic. After all, you first visited the count instead of me. Count Cremo must have welcomed you with wide open arms, knowing your devout feelings for him. Am I wrong?”

“Please save me, Your Majesty.” Lloyd dropped to the floor and bowed.

With that, the bitter smile on the queen changed into a satisfied one. And now her eyes subtly danced with amusement and contentment. “This is why I like you.”

“Excuse me...?” Lloyd slightly lifted his head to read her face.

“Never mind,” she said immediately and changed the subject. “Did everything go well in Hell?”

“Certainly, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“Everything is well with you? Are you injured anywhere?”

“As you can see, Your Majesty, I am completely fine, and-”

“And I’m sure that is due to my generosity and support?” said the queen.

“...”

“All right. This is enough small talk. Let us get to business.” Her eyes then grew icy. And she pulled no punches when she went on. “I ask you, Lloyd Frontera, did you request for an audience with me to solve the recent worries on my mind and request a reward in return?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” affirmed Lloyd.

Lloyd didn’t deny her assumptions. Instead, he found this kind of conversation with the queen convenient. There was no beating around the bush. It was straight to the point. And then he recalled the events that happened over a month ago. The foundation of the jewel at the Mermaid Kingdom. The jewel’s blueprint and key materials. The things he must do to attain them.

With those in mind, he replied, “Your Majesty’s estimation is all precise.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Then do you have an innovative solution to restore the authority of the imperial family that was diminished after the Bone Dragon wreaked havoc on the grand garden celebration?”

“Without a doubt, Your Majesty,” answered Lloyd as he nodded. He really did. He had somewhat guessed what would be worrying her and came up with a solution for her concern.

I knew it.

She was right about Lloyd and why he had come here. After all, he was a man who always calculated the gain. If he wasn’t convinced about the results, he wouldn’t have made his way here.

Thanks to his character, I can trust him to do the job.

A sense of relief and confidence flooded her heart. No one was as clever and reliable as Lloyd Frontera. The mere sight of him brimming with confidence made her feel that her problem was solved already. And so...

“Good. If your plan is that certain, I am sure you have already thought of the reward you want from me.” Her voice was now softer.

“That is also without a doubt, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd.

“Tell me in advance what you want.” Queen Magentano resolved to give him whatever he wanted, even if it was out of the line. Hear what he wants in advance since he was a reliable subject set to relieve her quandary. She wanted to cherish him and continue to have him under her wing. Feelings of generosity filled her heart.

And so, Lloyd began to speak rather shamelessly. “My trivial request is very simple, Your Majesty. I would like to request your permission... to pull out your palace from the ground.”

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Chapter 265: A Shameless Demand (2)

“Your Majesty. I ask you to... permit me to pull out your palace from the ground.”

“What...?” Widened eyes. Speechless voice. Lloyd, however, remained calm despite the queen’s reactions. A part of his mind flew back to what happened fifteen days ago.

I, too, was flustered.

It was right after the Kraken’s upset stomach settled down. Lloyd was thrilled about getting his hands on the blueprint for the Aotearoa, the Jewel of Truth, and was about to jump into action until something stopped him.

Then I learned that the key materials for construction are spread out in various parts of the world and have to be collected for the Jewel of Truth to function properly.

The blueprint enlightened Lloyd that tauranga was used to build the stylobates found in Magenta. It was used to build the Palace of Magenta. And that needed to be pulled out.

I abandoned everything there and flew here.

Lloyd recalled treating the Kraken and finding the foundation of the Jewel of Truth, which was thought to be only a legend. This merited him plenty of recognition from the merpeople. He became a star. Everywhere he went, the merpeople cheered, and he was showered with a plethora of gifts. One of them was lifetime access to the Mermaid Kingdom.

In exchange, I had to hand over the jjimjilbang’s operational rights to the queen.

However, Lloyd hardly looked upon it as a loss. In the first place, the jjimjilbang was built to acquire laborers set to be mobilized in the excavation project. But now that he had dug what he wanted, Lloyd was

certain that managing its operations, repairs, and maintenance would only slow down his plans. Generously handing over the jjimjilbang amidst the pleasant mood and working on his public image appeared to be more beneficial for him in the future.

After all, Lloyd would need the merpeople's help once he returned for the reconstruction. He'd have to use the merpeople for labor again anyway. So, earning plenty of brownie points from them while he had the chance sounded like a much better choice. That was why he donated the jjimjilbang without any hesitation, inviting explosive applause from the merpeople society at large.

Plus, I've become an honored citizen of the Mermaid Kingdom and earned the right to enter the kingdom without any restrictions for the rest of my life. There's also the magical necklace that protects me under the deep sea and the VVIP membership to jjimjilbang.

That wasn't the end of it. A likeability system was opened between him and the merpeople. He was now capable of earning RP by winning their hearts.

Well, I should say that I've become friends with the entire community of merpeople.

Thanks to the friendship, Lloyd was promised unreserved assistance in his future reconstruction of the Jewel of Truth. And yet, nobody pressured him to give his hand in rebuilding the demolished city. They assured him he could stay out of it since he was an honored guest.

Anyway, I've attained everything I could from there.

Just like that, he left the Mermaid Kingdom and was even escorted out by the queen. Her lightning-fast speed of swimming easily got them from the Arctic Ocean to the sea near Port Cremo, where Lloyd timely reunited with the Feliconia Ship on a nearby shore and paid off his remaining balance for using the ship. Then, he hopped on Ggoming before bidding farewell to the crew and flew all the way to Magenta, where he headed to the palace at once and requested the audience with the queen. Those were the series of events that Lloyd went through for the past fifteen days.

Haah. Tsk. Sure, I made the right call by coming here, but look at how cold her eyes are.

Lloyd felt bitter for some reason. The queen's eyes fixed on Lloyd were filled with burning intensity. At first, they were flustered, but now, she was shooting a stone-cold look at him with a straight face. But Lloyd understood her.

It's the same as randomly coming up to the queen and asking if I could take apart the palace.

Will she grab me by the collar? Or punch me in the gut? Lloyd was starting to feel anxiety creeping up in him when she spoke.

"Whew," sighed Queen Magentano, "You are always like this." She gave a chuckle. "Truly nasty. How do you always fluster me like this every time? But your request. That was not a joke, wasn't it?"

"It was not, Your Majesty," Lloyd answered seriously.

"Do you wish for me to permit you to pull out my palace from the ground?"

"Yes, Your Majesty." Lloyd didn't deny it. This was a critical moment, and the timing was perfect. She wanted to know his intentions.

"Not a common house or building but the palace? I suppose your outrageous request is backed by a reason I shall accept?"

"Yes, of course, Your Majesty."

"Tell me."

Feeling the cold gaze of the queen, Lloyd replied, "The palace was built using the ancient material called tauranga."

"So?"

"I wish to have my hands on the material."

“For what reason do you need it?”

Lloyd paused for a second before speaking. At last, he looked up at the queen with a serious face and said, “Please forgive me for being unable to reveal the purpose in detail. However, I can dare ascertain that you and the royal family shall not be harmed by this.” His answer was solemn and genuine.

Really, I am not trying to harm her or the royal family. It’s rather the opposite. I’m helping them. After all, she’ll be one of the victims of the restoration of destiny.

Just then, the future he glimpsed through the Ending Spoiler came to his mind. The queen’s left arm would become paralyzed. Though it didn’t get cut like in the novel, her arm suffered from paralysis as destiny fell back to its original track, which was just as bad as not having it.

In particular, since she’s a swordmaster, losing one arm is... awful. Nothing could compensate for that.

As such, to prevent the tragedy from happening, he had to attain tauranga, which could only happen if the palace was lifted from the ground. Lloyd bore his heart out to the queen but omitted talking about the restoration of destiny because it’d inevitably lead to a discussion of his identity from South Korea and the novel.

I should be ambiguous about that part while still making sure that she feels my sincerity. I need to create an atmosphere that’ll incline her to trust me.

Lloyd thought so. He believed her. He knew that the queen was way more intelligent than him, who only knew a few more things about the future. He decided to trust her excellent political instinct. And she didn’t disappoint.

“Ha.” She scoffed at last, her smile soon turning bitter. “You really are... a nasty person.”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“Not at all. I can’t not trust you. Anyway, if you wanted to, there are many ways you could hurt me and the imperial family. You would not even have to go as far as visiting me and making a request like now. How could I not trust your words of assurance?” Queen Magentano spoke, almost in a self-mocking manner. She could only trust him. It was a simple matter.

Lloyd Frontera. He is already powerful enough. Well beyond my sphere of control.

It was really true. The Bone Dragon. Grandmaster Javier. Two of them were loyal to Lloyd. There were more.

The Sand and Steel Orc Tribe.

Queen Magentano remembered the report from her informant. It said that the Frontera family had a blood alliance with the barbarous orc tribe composed of Herculean warriors, which was on her list of potential threats in the eastern wasteland. Tying blood alliance with the orcs meant the Frontera family was part of their family. In other words, the orc tribe coalition across the world would raise their weapons and wage war at the request of the Frontera family.

Bone Dragon. Sir Asrahan. Orc tribe. These three alone allowed the Frontera fiefdom to surpass the power of the royal family already. More than that, if he wanted to, he could establish a new dynasty in a blink of an eye.

Queen Magentano thought that Lloyd wouldn’t have resorted to this complicated method if the latter desired to hurt her or the imperial family. Making the tedious trip down here? Requesting with a cap in hand? None of that was necessary. He just needed to wield his power.

As such, it should be better to trust the intention of his request.

She concluded that giving him full trust was a better way to solidify her relationship with him and politically benefit her and the imperial family. Wrapping up her thoughts, she spoke. “Good. Since I have never doubted your allegiance, I shall continue that pattern this time as well.”

“Words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Highness,” Lloyd answered.

“Tsk. You and your gratitude,” tutted the queen, recognizing his repetitive expression. “You only visit me when you want something.”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“And you ask for forgiveness when you are out of the things to say.”

Lloyd clamped his mouth shut, feeling exposed.

“But there is no need for the embarrassed look on your face. After all, I heeded to your request of pulling out my perfectly fine palace from the ground. I only ask you to avoid damaging the palace in the process.

“Of course, Your Majesty,” Lloyd promised firmly. “I will carefully carry out the construction so that no unnecessary damage will occur.”

“While the necessary damages will occur, right?” She gave him a sharp look.

Lloyd decided not to respond to her.

“It is all good,” she went on, “I already granted your request, so I can understand that much at least. I shall be announcing to the public that the regular maintenance on the palace will be done with a special method this time.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” And with that, Lloyd rose and was about to leave when the queen stopped him.

“But first, I believe we have discussed only half of the matter. What do you think?” She looked at him sharply.

“Oh,” said Lloyd, “Do you mean the solution for your worries?”

“Indeed.”

“Do you wish to hear everything in detail right at this moment?” Lloyd pointed his finger to the ground.

“Of course. Continue one.”

“Yes, Your Majesty. If that is the case, may I have permission to whisper it in your ears?”

“Come closer.”

At her permission, Lloyd carefully walked closer to her desk and leaned forward, whispering something very softly into her ears.

“So, the plan is... In order to revive the damage done to the royal family due to the Bone Dragon... A shocking method is called for... Even if officials around you oppose... Everything will be resolved...”

Lloyd spelled out his scheme to the queen, trying to be as detailed as possible. Meanwhile, as she listened, her eyes changed.

“...”

What kind of madman was he? She dazedly stared at him. But not for long. A quick decision was made. “Good. Do as you say.”

“Words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd’s confident smile spread around the office.

♣

Fifteen days passed. During these days, the Magentano royal family was busy making preparations for the celebration of the reconstruction of the Termina Garden, which had taken over several months.

“Tsk, tsk. As if this event will change anything,” a foreign ambassador tutted as he arrived at the venue.

“You could not be more right, Hahaha.”

On the night of the ball, carriages carrying diplomatic ambassadors and prominent figures residing in the capital arrived at the garden. The facial expressions of the guests waltzing out of the carriages were subtle. There was a subtle derision on their faces, which was directed to the House of Magentano.

“This is simply between us,” the same ambassador whispered to his aide, “The House of Magentano has been parading their power by increasing their military spending and whatnot, but don’t they seem surprisingly unstable?”

“What do you mean, ambassador?”

“Shh,” ordered the ambassador. “Lower your voice. How long have you been working as my aide?”

“About two years, my lord,” replied the aide.

“Tsk,” he grunted. “That must account for your incomprehension. Listen carefully. If I were Queen Magentano, I would not hold a banquet like this after the incident caused by the bone dragon. I would instead hold a large-scale military parade.”

“A military parade?”

“Yes,” the ambassador nodded, his eyes shining. “What happened during the bone dragon’s commotion? Did you forget how miserably helpless the queen was? Everyone at the banquet clearly saw it. That is why I am saying this. What is the purpose of ramping up military power if she does not plan to use them for an event like this? She ought to boast her strength in front of everyone.”

“Are you saying that she would be able to recover the authority she lost from the previous incident that way?”

“Yes!” The ambassador nodded earnestly. “This banquet will not change anything. And yet, the queen holds the same banquet in the same format as before to reclaim her lost glory. Tsk, tsk. What is the point of possessing

great strength? When you cannot even take advantage of it? Do you not agree?”

“Oh, yes. I think so too.”

It wasn’t that the mockery was present only between this ambassador and his aide. Almost every guest present at the banquet was gossiping among themselves about the futility of this event in making things right. It was nothing but another invitation for mockery. They chitchatted and scorned the queen for being ignorant and losing her political sensibilities, most of them doubting and looking down on the House of Magentano for organizing this banquet. Thus, blinded by their arrogance and disdain for the kingdom, they had no clue that deep into the dark woods, the extraordinary and jaw-dropping host of the party was getting ready with Lloyd.

“So,” reminded Lloyd, “You have to do well tonight. Got it?”

Clack! It was the Bone Dragon dressed in a gigantic bow tie and tuxedo. Draggy clacked in grave determination to entertain the guests.

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Chapter 275: A Special Host (1)

“You have to do well tonight. Got it?”

Clack! Draggy earnestly nodded at his master’s words. Lloyd. The most awesome master in the world. The incomparable, fantabulous commander of the Skeleton Corps. Draggy thought to itself that its master was the best. Oh, how dearly it missed him!

Clack! Creak! Draggy recalled how it had been spending its days as it rubbed the giant bow tie around its neck. The loneliness. The boredom. Draggy was on cloud nine when it met Lloyd back in Hell and extremely excited when it came back to the capital through the Hell gate with him. But its joy and elation last only for a short while. The emotions were banished from its heart when Lloyd requested something.

“Draggy. You’ll cause an uproar if someone sees you, so go hide for now. Head over there. That’s the east direction.”

And then he went on to say...

“Keep flying, and you’ll see a giant mountain range. That’s the eastern mountain range. Hang around there for a while. Be friendly with the orcs if you bump into them. You’re a good boy, Draggy. If you behave, I’ll introduce you to your brothers in the Skeleton Corps. Okay, off you go.”

So, Draggy did exactly that. There was no reason to disobey Lloyd. It flew toward the eastern range and even took a nice bath in a deep lake there. That was when Draggy bumped into the orc tribe. Upon seeing Draggy, the orcs roared and greeted Draggy, and their welcome reminded the dragon of Lloyd’s advice. Determined to be faithful to its master’s order to act friendly around the orcs, Draggy returned with a welcoming roar. This got the orcs to convulse in joy. Their reaction was wild. They crawled on top of its body and pet Draggy with their various types of axes, spears, and hammers. Sometimes, they even tied Draggy’s whole body with ropes and twisted and turned its bones. And since the orcs were strong, their massages

were far more refreshing and relaxing than the typical massages or chiropractic treatments from pseudo-experts.

From that moment onward, hanging out at Lake Kapua with the orc warriors became a part of Draggy's daily routine. They were joyful days. But still, the emptiness in the corner of its breastbone lingered, primarily because it missed Lloyd.

Clack! Creak! Despite the great fun it had with the orcs and their refreshing massages, an unquenchable emptiness lingered in its heart. Draggy yearned to spend time with its master. It wanted to play, work, and get complimented. But such an opportunity didn't come because Lloyd didn't call for Draggy, even when he was back at the fiefdom!

Creak! Though Draggy was wistful, it endured because it knew very well why Lloyd wasn't calling or introducing it to its skeleton brothers.

Clack... Draggy believed it was all because it was ugly. Particularly because of its ugly skull. Draggy was convinced that Lloyd's negligence had much to do with his embarrassment of showing it to the world. Whenever such thoughts crossed its mind occasionally, Draggy was terribly discouraged and became envious of handsome creatures whose existence alone wasn't fair. Sad and resentful, Draggy grew tired of playing with the orc warriors. Making up its mind to go astray, it sank to the bottom of the lake and stayed there all day until it, out of the blue, received a signal from Lloyd.

Creak! It immediately rocketed out of the lake as if it was never sulking and fluttered its wings to the location provided by Lloyd's optional skill, Zombie Domination. And it arrived at the capital in a flash and basked in the joy of reuniting with Lloyd. And today, it was given a grand mission.

"Remember! Who's the main character of today's event?" asked Lloyd.

Clack!

"Right!" exclaimed Lloyd. "It's you. So, the success or failure of this event will depend on your performance. That makes you the main character of today. So, tell me, what should you do?"

Creak!

“Okay. You remember it. Follow the script I recited to you a while ago. On my cue, appear at the designated spot doing the pose I told you. Be powerful, dashing, and forceful. And then?”

Clack!

“Good job,” complimented Lloyd, “You do remember. Match the queen’s pace. Got it?”

Creak!

“Awesome. My. You’re a smart boy. Do well here, and you’ll be able to confidently appear in front of other people. You won’t need to hide anymore. So, do your best!”

Clack!

After walking through the whole plan with Draggy one last time, Lloyd headed back to the banquet. Draggy gave an earnest nod as it gazed at the back of Lloyd’s head. If it did well today, it could always be with Lloyd. Resolved, Draggy fixed its clothes, making sure that its bow tie wasn’t crooked and tux was wrinkle-free. Draggy checked over and over again. That was how anxious it was about this job.

Clack...

Draggy was worried that people might get shocked by its looks. Even though Lloyd assured it that it was all fine, Draggy was still worried. A few moments later, Lloyd’s signal came.

Now!

Kaboom! At the signal, Draggy flew up and soared into the night sky, its tuxedo tail fluttering against the wind. It then checked the direction and angle of the full moon before flying to the spot that masked the moon and filled the sky with its silhouette. After finding this spot, Draggy filled the night sky with its body and let out a roar.

...!

The roar was controlled and silent. But its shockwave shook the sky, making everything tremble at the bouquet that was several miles away. The musicians' instruments vibrated. The wine splashed inside their glasses. One of the foreign diplomats disparaging tonight's banquet and the House of Magentano quivered in shock.

"I-It's the Bone Dragon!"

His loud screech and shivering finger pointing to the sky immediately sent a ripple of fear across the banquet. The guests berated their luck. The Bone Dragon had to appear today, the very night Queen Magentano was celebrating the recovery from the previous disaster, and they happened to be here. Everyone felt a twinge of bitterness as well as fear and couldn't stop thinking about how much of a nightmare this was. Furthermore, since the queen failed to subdue the Bone Dragon and was left helpless previously, everyone guessed in despair that they'd end up dead tonight. The Bone Dragon touched down to the ground.

Boooom!

"Ackkk!"

"Run for your lives!"

Draggy's landing brought a terrible tremor to the ground, and as it completely covered the sky by just standing, everyone's heart sank. Terror drained the color from their faces. Dead, I'm dead, they thought. They were frozen in place from shock and couldn't even think of escaping. No one could muster up the courage to run away. Just then, the moonlight shed light on its appearance, and everyone rubbed their eyes in shock.

"Eh...?"

Why is the Bone Dragon dressed in a tux? And what was that bow tie around its neck? Was it a trend among dragons now to eat people while

wearing a tux? All sorts of outrageous thoughts dominated their brains when something entirely uncalled for took place.

“My Bone Dragon, the ultimate weapon of destruction and the guardian of the House of Magentano. My faithful servant. Don’t shock everyone here.”

It was Queen Magentano, and she was striding toward the Bone Dragon with only a sword around her. What was more, the sword was still in its sheath, and her gait was so relaxed and confident, as though she was walking toward her servant.

Everyone thought among themselves that this was it for her. This was the end for Queen Magentano, an unwed and childless monarch who had no one to pass down the throne to.

But something strange took place: nothing happened. The Bone Dragon didn’t stomp and kill her, which was something everyone expected to happen. Instead, the dragon lowered its head at her in the utmost polite and careful manner, like a loyal dog bringing its head forward to its master. The dragon lowered its body, propping its jaw against the ground and giving its forehead to the queen, who drew her sword. She then touched the dragon’s temples for a second with it as if she was softly tapping them or like she would to a knight’s shoulder at their ordination.

“I am aware of your feelings,” Queen Magentano said solemnly. “I am aware how you struggled with a sense of guilt and accountability for your commotion last time. I only ask that you pay for your wrongdoing by protecting us instead of writhing in guilt.”

Clack! The Bone Dragon nodded its giant skull. Her mouth formed a faint smile.

“Then, as a proud subject of the House of Magentano and special host of tonight’s banquet, can you provide assurance to the guests?”

Creak! Draggy nodded once again, and its gaze flickered over to the guests, who all flinched when their eyes met. They couldn’t wrap their heads around what was happening. They wondered if they were having a weird,

eccentric dream and gulped dryly, feeling delusional and bewitched at the same time.

Then Draggy stood up and brought something out from its tux. Giant signs. They had Lloyd written down on them.

[I won’t hurt you.]

Absolute silence fell over the crowd. Draggy brought out the next sign.

[I won’t bite you.]

Flip!

[I won’t hit you.]

Everyone was relieved to see that. Even so, they feared that a simple sneeze from the dragon would make them die from pain. As they thought so, Draggy flipped to the final sign.

[The Bone Dragon, Draggy, is your friend. ♡]

As silence heavily fell over the place, the Bone Dragon closed the signs and made a heart sign with its forelegs. Then it sat back down like a dog that was ordered to sit, its buttocks against the floor and looking up. It was only then that the people started to make sense of the situation.

“Haha, ha! Hahaha...”

“That is... Ha... This is... Hahaha.”

The heavy silence started to wear off as they started to realize what happened. The Bone Dragon wasn’t here to invade the banquet. It was just an attendee, and what was more, it came at the order of Queen Magentano. So, in other words...

Queen Magentano really did... suppress the Bone Dragon! Is that how it became a follower of hers?

Everyone had jeered at the queen for her incompetent response to the previous commotion and the Bone Dragon. They gloated in joy and even refused to believe her when she refuted that the Bone Dragon had been taken care of after a fierce battle. But no one trusted her and dismissed it as nothing but a pathetic bluff and an excuse to save face. Everyone had regarded her claim as a lie...

But she was telling the truth. She... really suppressed the dragon and took it under her command.

Fright filled their eyes at the realization.

This is nuts! She brought in the Bone Dragon as one of her followers!

What this meant was clear. The Bone Dragon, which was stronger than normal dragons, had been tamed and joined her forces.

There is no country now in the Lorasian Continent that can fight alone against the Magentano Kingdom.

Yes, this moment marked the birth of the Magentano Kingdom as the most powerful kingdom on the continent. They were untouchable.

Gulp. The diplomats swallowed dryly, and a host of thoughts filled their heads, and their eyes moved busily. The expression of mockery was completely gone from their faces. Instead of mockery, there was only a sense of alarm and urgency. They nervously thought about sending a message to their home countries as soon as possible to prevent getting into any conflicts with the House of Magentano at all costs. Seeing this, Lloyd, in the corner of the banquet, grinned as he watched.

Whew. I can almost hear how quickly their eyes are widening.

A burst of laughter escaped Lloyd as his gaze traveled across the dismayed diplomats that used to mock the Royal House of Magentano and the queen. This confirmed something for him. Today’s plan was a victory. Now, Queen Magentano only had to fulfill her promise and make a declaration. Then all plans would be finalized.

Sometime later, Queen Magentano’s gaze swept over the guests at the banquet. She was now the queen of the most powerful kingdom in the Lorasian Continent. She was the Iron Fist Queen, Alicia Termina Magentano.

And she declared, “I hereby announce to everyone gathered at this place.” She then pointed at Lloyd, which immediately attracted attention and caused everyone to focus on him.

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Chapter 276: A Special Host (2)

“I hereby stand before you to make a declaration in everyone’s presence.” Queen Magetano’s voice boomed, reaching the corners of the banquet hall. Everyone’s gaze followed where she pointed - Lloyd was standing there.

“As I revealed tonight, the Bone Dragon has become a loyal subject of the House of Magentano,” the queen went on. “However, this great achievement is not mine or that of the imperial family. I am here to reveal the praiseworthy individual whose identity has remained hidden from everyone.”

All the top foreign diplomats, nobles, and other prominent figures frowned when they heard this. Each of them started to think carefully about what that could mean. The queen continued.

“The contributors are Lloyd Frontera, whom you are looking at, and his personal guard, Knight Javier Asrahan. The day the Bone Dragon attacked us, these two men bravely took action first, drawing their swords and standing shoulder to shoulder with me on the battlefield.”

Her words meant that the two men had joined her in a fight against the Bone Dragon. Astonishment and awe filled everyone’s eyes.

“Lloyd Frontera, in particular, did not hesitate to risk his life to protect me, and he accomplished the incredible feat of suppressing the Bone Dragon. Thus, I hereby declare…”

Everyone looked from the queen to Lloyd, their ears perked up to catch what the queen had to say.

“Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera county, shall be a meritorious retainer of the House of Magentano. He shall be granted the privilege of legal immunity. He shall not be arrested in dishonor in any event. My judgment, rather than that of other nobles, shall be the sole determiner to decree a punishment for him.”

Everyone at the scene, the foreign diplomats and powerful nobles of the kingdom, gaped in shock as fright filled their eyes. The designation as a meritorious retainer and the right to legal immunity. Both of these were extraordinary.

Their astonishment made sense. The designation was rarely ever given. It was bestowed only to those who accomplished something equal to helping the founding of a nation, restoring power to a deteriorating throne, saving an imperial family from downfall, or preventing the kingdom from destruction. Simply put, only those who saved the kingdom could merit such an appointment.

As such, the authorities vested in those individuals were extremely powerful. The title alone awarded them the treatment equal to a duke or marquess. In addition, a host of other privileges, too many to enumerate, were granted to them. The best had to be the privilege of legal immunity, which immunized them from dishonorable arrests even for grave charges such as treason. And they also received the right to be exempted from the adjudication of nobles. As such, the monarch had to step in for the punishment of meritorious retainers.

This clearly meant one thing. Now, Lloyd was below one person but above everyone. He was the second most powerful figure in the nation apart from the monarch. No one had earned this stature for the past 130 years in the Magentano Kingdom. He was the first.

What's happening...?

The diplomats' heads were now in a muddle. The designation was as breaking news as the subjugation of the Bone Dragon because now, the center of power among the Magentano nobles was about to shift. Such a future seemed to loom over them as they racked their brains on how they ought to format their messages back home. But they weren't the only ones overwhelmed by these thoughts and concerns. The nobles were also troubled.

Haha. Hahaha.

Various emotions gripped them. Lloyd Frontera. He used to be nothing but the eldest son of a noble family in a remote land of the east. A nobody these major nobles paid no attention to and never heard or took an interest in. But this had changed in the past few years.

Starting with the Llo-Javi suspension bridge, he saved the queen from being assassinated. And in the process, news broke out that his personal knight was a sword master. What was more, he prevented the Monster Domino phenomenon from destroying the kingdom's eastern area, accommodating tens and thousands of refugees and giving them new homes. This accomplishment designated his fiefdom as the hub for reconstruction in the east by the queen and elevated his family to the stature of a county. What about now? He was no longer the eldest son of a count. He was now appointed as a meritorious retainer, the first one in 130 years.

I never thought I'd witness this in my lifetime...

The hearts of nobles sincerely loyal to the queen raced in excitement. They internalized their emotions as they clenched their fists. They truly admired and congratulated Lloyd for his honor as a meritorious retainer. However, some of the power-grubbing nobles reacted differently.

How dare that country bumpkin...

They stared at Lloyd coldly but couldn't let their emotions show as the queen made the following declaration.

"Moreover, I proclaim thenceforth that I shall dispatch my loyal Bone Dragon to my faithful servant, Loyd Frontera. The Bone Dragon will reside in Frontera County until I order otherwise. Until then, the Bone Dragon shall support the reconstruction efforts of Frontera county in the east."

"..."

Now, their lips were sealed in sheer fright. Honor, authority, privilege, and now power? Truly, this was overwhelming and shocking. The nobles that used to look down on Lloyd could not even dare think about showing their

envy now. Queen Magentano scoffed when she saw everyone's reaction. A faint smile appeared on her lips, and she looked at Lloyd.

It's as I expected. Lloyd Frontera. What a sly and cunning man he is. Everything he said was correct.

Just then, she recalled the conversation that took place 15 days ago when Lloyd visited her office.

"Your Majesty," suggested Lloyd, "I will lend the Bone Dragon to you. So, you will need to declare at the official event that you will lend the Bone Dragon to me."

To this, she replied, "Do you mean I should announce I'm lending you the Bone Dragon that you will lend me?"

"Yes, Your Majesty." Lloyd approached and whispered in her ears with a cunning smile on his face. "I am aware Your Majesty is worried about how you will restore the imperial family's reputation that was damaged from the previous incident with the Bone Dragon. As such, I believe this method is the best way to solve it."

"Do you suggest we reveal the Bone Dragon by opening the same banquet?" Queen Megentano shot an incredulous look.

"That is exactly the case, Your Majesty." Lloyd nodded.

"And assuage those who were left panic-stricken when the Bone Dragon appeared."

"Yes, Your Majesty," said Lloyd affirming once more, "That is my exact point. The kingdom's reputation you are worrying about has been damaged because of the Bone Dragon's uproar. Therefore, all you have to do is show that the Bone Dragon is loyal to you."

"Certainly. That sounds promising." Queen Magentano found herself nodding. Restore her dampened glory by tackling the very source. Nothing could ascertain better results than this. "So, your suggestion to announce

that I will be lending the Bone Dragon to you must come from your desire to let it freely roam around people, right?”

“Ahaha... Truly, Your Majesty is the only one who understands me.” Lloyd’s embarrassed smile confirmed one thing for the queen.

Surely, his goal is to live a peaceful life in the province.

At last, Queen Magentano was able to get a vague understanding of what Lloyd was after and why he had come to her.

He came to gain control of the Bone Dragon, but there are currently zero accounts of the Bone Dragon being sighted in the kingdom. In other words, this means that Lloyd had kept the dragon out of everyone’s eyes, probably because he wished to avoid creating suspicion or a scandal.

The Bone Dragon had ransacked the palace and disappeared into thin air. What would happen if the news spreads that the eldest son of the Frontera family masters the Bone Dragon? It’d bring about a wild scandal.

He has been considerate of me, and he plans on remaining unchanged. Up to this point, even now, and in the future as well.

Queen Magentano saw Lloyd in a new light. Right now, Lloyd was advising her to advertise to the world that the Bone Dragon, under Lloyd’s lead, was loyal to her.

Moreover, if I make the declaration that I am lending the Bone Dragon to the Frontera family... Yes. He would be able to have the Bone Dragon around without any hassle while saving my and the royal family’s tainted reputation at the same time.

The solution was beneficial for both of them. Lloyd could put the Bone Dragon to use without being conscious of the prickling stares of people, and she would restore her authority as the queen. Aside from this, there were other potential benefits.

“Hmm, good,” accepted Queen Magentano, smiling at the idea. “I shall take your suggestion. Since everyone outside and inside the kingdom will be more careful around me if things develop as you say.”

“Yes, Your Majesty, that shall be the case,” said Lloyd as he moved back.

“Right. Our reputation suffered horrific damage during the Bone Dragon’s uproar. In the meantime, I’m sure everyone was laughing at us. It must be the case even now. However, if I reveal the Bone Dragon’s loyalty toward us at the banquet, which will happen in fifteen days... Ha. Everyone will think twice about the meaning behind my silence and patience.”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” acknowledged Lloyd. “They will realize that your composed response was a silence filled with strength, the time used to compose a hit list.”

“Yes, indeed.”

It will indeed be the case. She naturally thought so. Even though the actual events would differ from what they advertise, the snickering nobles and diplomats would regard the Magentano House’s silence as intentional. They will think that despite slaying the dragon, the queen had purposefully remained silent and endured all the mockery to assess everyone.

“If events develop that way,” she continued, “No potential enemies inside and outside my kingdom will regard me as an easy target after this.”

“It shall be the case, Your Majesty. Even if an unfavorable or unfortunate incident ever occurs to the imperial family in the future, everyone will have to think twice about their reaction after seeing what will happen.”

“Truly, this event will set an example of our kingdom.”

The House of Magentano would not be looked down on by anyone, and that image was set to bring in a myriad of benefits, including power and political dominance.

Truly, what he said was exactly right.

Jostling out of the conversation with Lloyd in her trance, Queen Magentano gazed through the banquet hall. The frightened and shocked expressions on the faces of top diplomats and nobles were evident. She was satisfied. Their reactions didn't betray her expectations. In particular, the sight of Lloyd's astonishment, which was a rare sight, satisfied her the most.

You requested me to make an announcement about the Bone Dragon. But I have other thoughts. The Bone Dragon was yours to begin with. And yet, you want me to pretend otherwise? That makes me feel like I am your puppet.

As such, she presented Lloyd with a special gift that wasn't mentioned in the deal, adding one more declaration about Lloyd's elevation of stature as the meritorious retainer. And now, Lloyd was throwing a goggle-eyed stare at the queen, who held his gaze with a smile in her eyes. Lloyd could only smile back.

Wow. She got me good this time.

Lloyd once again felt that the queen was an extraordinary person. She wasn't someone to mess with. No, anyone who was careless in dealing with her would face dire consequences. A bitter smile appeared on Lloyd's face.

Woah. I've become a meritorious retainer. Is this for real?

He had never made such a request nor expected it. Thanks to the surprise, he understood something.

The queen is trying to secure me as her political ally.

Lloyd could feel her intentions with every fiber of his being.

She must think my powers surpassed hers. So, instead of keeping me in check, she chose to recruit me to her side.

This decision from the queen couldn't have been an easy one. Normally, kings and queens sought out chances to drag down or kill any powerful individuals under them. But Queen Magentano approached the matter

differently by bringing Lloyd onto her side. Her intentions came off even more clearly when he learned of the great privileges granted to meritorious retainers, particularly the right of legal immunity.

The nobles can't hold me in check anymore and only the queen can bestow a lawful judgment on me. This means that she'll bear the political liability and condemnation in the case my family does something wrong. It also means that she won't be willing to let go of me without a fight. Ha. She's a smart queen.

Part of him wondered if the title "Magentano Carry" had a large influence on the queen's decision this time.

Anyway, I've gotten everything I can from the situation.

Whether he became a meritorious retainer or not, his goal remained unchanged.

Once I stop the restoration of destiny, I'll live the rest of my life in my fiefdom in peace.

Lloyd remembered his life plan once again. He made a steadfast resolution: From now on, he shall not be baited by the queen's sweet talks. His life would be that of a rich, unemployed landlord. He carved this resolution into his bones, heart, intestines, and soul. And when the following day came, Lloyd kickstarted his project to lift up the palace from the ground and find the tauranga there.

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Chapter 277: An Even More Shameless Demand (1)

Lloyd was in the Magenta Palace, which strangely appeared like a giant, half-buried egg. It was structured this way to prevent dragons from lifting it up from the ground. Lloyd was there, carefully inspecting all its nooks and crannies.

Let's see... Survey.

[Scanning will begin.]

Bzzt! Lloyd activated his surveying skill, and various types of information appeared everywhere he could see. There was everything there could be, pieces of information about the structure's design, weight, strength, compound method, etc... He could even see the price of the land because he activated the first optional skill of the surveying skill.

Ding dong.

[Skill Option 1: Land Price Appraisal has been activated.]

[You can appraise the land you measure. (Error rate: +/- 5%)]

Frankly, Lloyd wanted to find out the worth of the palace as it sat at the center of the kingdom. He figured he might as well satisfy his curiosity since he had to run a scan on the palace anyway. The result was jaw-droppingly shocking. He felt a rush of self-hate spread throughout his entire body.

Wooow. I somewhat expected this, but it's obscenely expensive.

His mouth hung open when he saw the price. It was unimaginably, devilishly expensive. The district of Gangnam in central Seoul was nothing compared to this. The value of one corner of the palace was enough to purchase the entire Frontera County and still leave enough money to buy about 1,000 meals.

It’s quite literally priceless.

Come to think of it, such a price made sense. After all, the House of Magentano was currently enjoying its golden days in history. The queen was a mighty sword master, backed by great lords in the province who gave her unwavering allegiance. On top of it all, she now had the Bone Dragon, which just meant another formidable weapon was added to her already stable and strong political and military arsenal.

Though technically, the Bone Dragon is mine.

But people didn’t know that. They thought that the dragon was loyal to the queen. In their knowledge, the Bone Dragon was dispatched to Frontera County because she ordered it to go.

All of these factors contributed to the dramatic hike in the palace’s value. Now, it’s at an overwhelmingly high and unreachable level that even its long-standing enemy, the sultan’s kingdom, will have to submit.

Literally speaking, the Magentano Kingdom was a global hegemony. So, it went without saying that the price of its land had skyrocketed.

Ha... Crap. I’m jealous.

As he continued his thoughts, a pang of envy crept up in him. But he soon shook his head, telling himself that now wasn’t the time to be concerned about trivial matters like the price of land. He urgently needed to find some tauranga, and the Jewel of Truth had to be constructed so that the status quo would continue without the restoration of destiny.

I don’t have much time.

Just then, Lloyd remembered that the count was set to fall off the horse in less than three years. To be more exact, he had two years and seven or eight months, give or take. Someone might say that Lloyd had enough time. It was longer than the required period of mandatory military service in South Korea, after all. But to Lloyd, it didn’t feel long at all.

I doubt I'll be able to retrieve the key materials for construction in time. The construction of the jewel is still left for me to do, and I need to find a way to stop the restoration of destiny after building it. And it'll take more time to execute the solution I find. Really, time isn't on my side.

When Lloyd thought about all the work ahead of him, he could only think about how much time he lacked.

I don't have time to dawdle around here.

So he affirmed his resolution once again. It was to make the most of his time and minimize the amount of trials and errors he went through to save time. And that was the very reason why he was conducting a survey at the moment.

"Are you certain, Young Master, that there's tauranga in this palace?"

"Of course." Lloyd looked at Javier, who was walking by his side as he asked. "So, we have to find it."

"Do you plan on harvesting it once you do?"

"Yeah. Just that. Nothing else." Clean and neat." Lloyd shrugged. "Look, I told the queen I'd lift up the entire palace, but realistically, that would be too wasteful."

"By wasteful, what do you mean?" There was genuine curiosity in Javier's voice.

"The situation will get too complicated. Think about it," said Lloyd, "What do you think will happen if I lift this palace up like I'm pulling radishes? You think it will remain intact?"

"Even I can see that will not be the case," replied Javier calmly.

"Right? It's going to take someone with extraordinary strength to lift up the palace without causing any damage. Even if the Bone Dragon and Bibeong worked together for the job, it wouldn't be enough. Unless Dragon King Verkis comes out to help us."

It was true. Bibeong and the Bone Dragon would only cause serious damage to the palace by doing so. To avoid any damage to the palace, it had to be plucked out in one almighty and clean pull that ensured an equally clean return. The only person Lloyd knew who could do it was Dragon King Verkis.

That sleepy dragon has actually done it twice before. Moreover, I even saw there were two palaces standing tall in his cave as if they were decorations. Those palaces hardly had any damage on them.

But bringing the dragon king here was impossible. As far as Lloyd was concerned, Verkis was the laziest creature in existence, so there was a chance that Lloyd would only invite wrath from the king if he tried to make him move.

“Anyway,” went on Lloyd, “If I lift up the palace and cause damage, I’ll have to make repairs. I already have a mountain of work to do, so I don’t have the time to do repairs. So-”

“Your plan is to locate the tauranga and just take out the area with the pieces of stone,” finished Javier in understanding.

“That’s exactly right. Like popping a pimple.”

That would minimize the damage to the structure. In addition, it would cut down the time needed for construction.

“So, I need to hurry and find the tauranga here. Better if it’s in a spot conducive for us to harvest.”

“But,” pointed out Javier, “It appears that you have already surveyed all the convenient areas to harvest the stone.”

“Yeah, so I’m starting to get sad.”

Lloyd sighed at length. It was just what Javier had said. Lloyd had wished for the tauranga to be found in an easy, harvestable spot. Reasoning that at least one or two pieces of it had to be an easy find, Lloyd checked the roofs

first, followed by the ceilings, pillars, and floors. But the stone was nowhere to be found in any of those places. Lloyd was starting to get restless.

Tsk. It's going to be troublesome if I find all of the stone underground or around the palace's foundation.

Lloyd direly wished that wouldn't be the case. Begging and pleading, he tensed his eyes and continued his survey as he scanned every palatial corner for over three days. He even was granted access to secret places and vaults with the generous cooperation of the queen. But even still, tauranga was nowhere to be found. By then, Lloyd's anxiety grew worse, along with his dry, bloodshot eyes. And finally, two more days later, he discovered pieces of tauranga.

"And... it had to be here out of everywhere... Really?" Lloyd heaved a sigh. Once again, he realized that his life never went easily. Why? It was because he had found the tauranga at the far bottom portion of the palace's foundation.

I wouldn't have found it without my optional skill.

Lloyd gazed down below. The chunks of tauranga were in the stone chamber, the lowest underground floor. The humidity was so thick down there that various types of molds fought each other to find more space. To be more exact, Lloyd was studying a giant rock beneath several layers of stones. That was the tauranga that Lloyd had been direly searching for. But its location was extremely, utterly, and seriously problematic.

I'm screwed.

They were inserted in the foundation that supported the weight of the palace. To be more exact, they made up the backbone of the palatial foundation's isolated piers

Okay. I can't just take them out. If I were to compare... Hmm, yeah. Yes, it'd be like taking out and replacing the stakes that hold the entire weight of a skyscraper without toppling it off.

Or it was the same as flicking the bottom of a Jenga tower without toppling it over. In other words, the tauranga here was used as the backbone for the isolated piers in order to support the palace's foundation. The worst thing was that all twelve of them were used separately. What would happen if Lloyd haphazardly pulled them out?

The palace will sink.

Just like a Jenga Tower that topples by wrongfully removing the bottom blocks, the foundation of the palace was set to sink and bring about a disaster. One way to prevent this from happening was to prepare stones that were the same in size and strength as the tauranga used for the pier and throw them in as Lloyd pulled everything out. It would be a quick exchange like replacing a part of a machine. But the process of getting there, as well as the clean-up afterward, appeared to be quite challenging.

Tsk. Should I approach this by digging from the top until the foundation appears? No. That won't do. For starters, each piece of the tauranga is way too big. The smallest piece of the stone looks to be nineteen feet in length. I'll have to turn over the floor here to salvage it out and make a tunnel to move the stone outside. Nah. The job will become too complicated if I do that.

Countless layers of floors, walls, and other structures stood between where he was positioned and outside the palace. Even if Lloyd managed to pull this piece of tauranga out safely, he would have to procure a pathway that was at least nineteen feet long.

Making the pathway isn't the hard part. The job after that is the challenge.

If he were to fix and repair the areas he dug out, it would only add another mountain of tasks to his list and also take a considerable amount of time. Lloyd didn't like that. If he could, he wanted to finish his job in the most efficient and orderly way possible.

I should think it over.

Lloyd got a feeling that the answer could be found in his wide breadth of knowledge. Once he sensed that, he went straight back to his VIP chamber and confined himself for two days in a row. He even skipped singing the lullaby for Javier during this time. He shut himself in his room, looking over various calculations and formulas based on the data he retrieved from surveying. He considered various factors, including the data points he retrieved of the foundation from surveying, the weight each pier held, and the expected changes that would occur to the ground if the tauranga was replaced with something else. Lloyd considered, predicted, prepared, experimented, calculated, and decided.

“Good.”

As soon as a decision was made, he left his room, entered the palace's main building, and requested the audience with the queen to the Lord of the Chamberlain. He was then led to the queen's office without much waiting, and he fell on his knees as soon as he entered and instantly got to business.

“Hail to Her Majesty. I, Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of Frontera County, am honored to be in the audience of the rightful owner of this land. I requested a meeting as I have an urgent request to make.”

“You have a request? And it is urgent?” asked Queen Magentano.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Queen Magentano frowned a little. It felt like Lloyd had been paying her visits with ease recently, and she got the feeling that his requests had become bolder and more open.

Soon, his arrogance will soar through the roof. Even though he’ll be careful not to cross any boundaries.

Given his cunning temperament, he would never do so. He’ll be insolent, but not to the point he’d cross the line. Doing so will only plunge him into the life he doesn’t want to live.

He will be a king after driving me out or declaring independence.

But that wasn’t the life Lloyd wanted. Laughter escaped her when she thought so.

His goal is to laze and idle around despite his abilities and powers. And yet, he works harder than anyone else in the world. No one will be more amusing and ironic than this man.

Lloyd amazed her. At the same time, she felt sorry for him. Her voice softened slightly more. “I see. You have the right to make a request. What is it?” What kind of outrageous request could he have come with? She felt curious and sorry at the same time.

“Yes, Your Majesty. If I dare may...” It was like Lloyd’s tongue was equipped with a twin-turbo engine. It smashed the gas pedal without hesitation. “I would like to request your assistance in performing what is called the freezing method. This is one of the methods to improve the foundation, and it was first used in the 19th century in the United Kingdom when they excavated a vertical shaft in its mines. It operates by inserting the freezing pipe and injecting -22 Fahrenheit icy liquid into the ground, freezing the moisture in the soil around the pipes like ice cream. After some time, the frozen pillars thicken until they touch each other, forming a giant ice wall. Since icy walls are extremely harder than the soils-”

“Pause there,” Queen Magentano raised her hand.

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd stopped and shamelessly stared at the queen, who held his gaze with a mildly sickening look. And a part of her felt that it’d be better to grant him whatever he wanted instead of hearing him out and bleeding her ears.

At last, she sighed and asked, “So, what is it that you want specifically?”

“Here it is, Your Majesty.”

Swoosh! Lloyd brought a note from his pocket and held it to the queen. And he spoke in a brazen and shameless manner as if he was demanding something back from her.

“I would like Your Majesty to permit me to freely use ‘The Heart of Winter,’ one of the three divine items of the House of Magentano.”

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Chapter 278: An Even More Shameless Demand (2)

The Heart of Winter was a divine marble that held the frigidity of the harshest season of the year. Despite its diameter of one inch, it was a malicious weapon that carried the freezing nature of winter and was one of the three divine items in the House of Magentano. Its power was beyond imaginable. If the frigid energy in the marble was ever released, the entire land around it would be swept with a chilling weather that was worse than the Ice Age. In just a single day, it could freeze over an entire fiefdom. Within ten days, the average temperature of a region as big as the Gyeonggi Province would plummet by twenty degrees. And the harvest for that year, as well as humans and livestock, would be ruined.

*That's what was said in the novel. Because of its destructive power, it was used only twice by the House of Magentano throughout history.*Lloyd recalled the mid-part of the story in the novel, where the Heart of Winter was used for the third time.

Queen Magentano utilizes it after she becomes a tyrant. She uses it to end the riot in the West and set an example of her terrorizing regime. Ultimately, this destroyed five fiefdoms and caused famine and calamity across the western region.

It was nothing short of a disaster. Too many people to count perished in the cold, and eventually, there was a great famine where countless people died of hunger the following year. That was how powerful and destructive the Heart of Winter was.

That should be why the queen is now giving me that look.

A wry smile escaped Lloyd. The queen's gaze wasn't that of fright or anger. It was the opposite. She was giving him a very pitiful look.

"My..." she sighed, her voice dripping with pity. "I should have stopped you when you busted your gut. I am responsible for this."

Lloyd wasn't sure where she was getting at.

“Humans are not livestock. We ought to rest and enjoy ourselves when we can. But you could not. You were always on the go to overcome the disaster in the east and reconstruct it after. That explains it. That is why. Tsk, tsk.”

“...”

“But it is all fine. You are my meritorious retainer. You may sometimes speak like a fool, a madman, or as if you are unwell. Even then, I can understand you. How could I not? How could I not when you ended up in this state after living such a diligent life?”

“Um... Your Majesty...”

“Yes,” the queen put on a benevolent smile, and her voice sounded like she was talking to a child. “Speak up. Speak up, Frontera.”

“Um, first of all,” pointed out Lloyd, “I am not a fool and did not go mad.”

“Of course, that’s what you say. I never heard of a madman who admitted his state of mind out loud.”

“The thing is, Your Majesty, I am completely fine,” Lloyd pressed further.

“Hmm. We will see,” said the queen.

“How can I prove that I am mentally sound to you, Your Majesty?”

“Will you marry me, Lloyd Frontera?”

“Please forgive me, Your Majesty.”

“Tsk, so you are sane.”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.” His wry smile deepened. Moving past the scary question, Lloyd wiped his cold sweat and went on, “I did not lose it, Your Majesty. I am not speaking gibberish, either. This request is being made after a series of precise predictions, calculations, and conclusions.”

“So,” mused the queen, “You wish to borrow the Heart of Winter for the foreseeable future?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“You should be aware of what kind of item that is.”

“Certainly, Your Majesty, and that is why I requested an audience with you.” Lloyd hung his head down. It was true. The Heart of Winter was a divine item owned by the royal family, and it wasn’t something anyone, including the man with unreserved trust from the queen, could easily get his hands on. Lending it would be the same as increasing the queen’s level of support by 100 folds.

Of course. Even the queen can’t unilaterally use the three divine items. It can be used only if the kingdom is on the brink of collapse or if the queen requests to use it. There needs to be a unanimous agreement from the nobles in the House of Peers for anyone to use it.

Of course, there were exceptions. A case in point was when Queen Magentano became a tyrant in the novel.

But that was only possible because she was an evil ruler and did everything she wanted to. She beheaded anyone, be it a noble or a subject, who disagreed with her on the spot. The kingdom was heading toward downfall. But now, the circumstances are different.

The queen was extremely rational, and the kingdom was very stable. The power of the queen and the custom of the nobles were in harmony as they led the national affairs. And so, Queen Magentano wouldn’t even think about unilaterally permitting Lloyd to use the Heart of Winter. So, if Lloyd wanted to use it, he’d have to ask the queen to file a request for its usage to the House of Peers and obtain its agreement.

“Whew. Then you should also know that this puts a political burden on my part,” said Queen Magentano.

“Certainly, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“And yet, you are making this request?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. For there is an imperative need for it.”

“An imperative need, you say. Explain.”

“Yes. If I may, Your Majesty, the Heart of Winter is essential to performing the freezing method I explained to you a couple of minutes ago.”

“Freezing method?” She frowned a little. “Your explanation was too esoteric for me to understand it clearly.”

“To put it simply,” said Lloyd, “the method involves freezing the moisture in the soil by inserting the pipes underground and injecting cold air.”

“Freeze the water in the ground?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. That will allow the ground to harden more than usual.”

“I believe it will. Much like how the soil gets as hard as a rock on wintry mornings. But what do you plan to achieve by freezing the ground?”

Lloyd did not hesitate to answer. “I plan to dig a large cave down the castle, Your Majesty.”

“A cave?” Queen Magentano frowned a little. But Lloyd was relieved. Her frown meant he managed to pique her interest.

Reading the positive atmosphere in the room, he quickly replied, “Yes, Your Majesty. It is to harvest the tauranga I mentioned to you the last time.”

“Right. You said you were looking for the material called tauranga. Are you saying that it is beneath this palace?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. To be more specific, they were used to make the isolated pillars of the foundation that were placed down like tree roots in the ground.”

“Will it not affect the palace if you pull those out?”

“That is where the freezing method comes into the picture.”

“Be more specific.”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Lloyd replied, sensing things were going somewhere. And then he began to rattle off, “Once the ground freezes and becomes more firm than usual, it will allow the vertical shafts I dig under the palace to hold still without falling apart. And it will also give me a bit of time until I replace the pieces of tauranga with a replacement stone.”

What he said was true. The freezing method was first developed in the nineteenth century in the United Kingdom, and it allowed excavations of vertical shafts to be done safely and free from collapse. In modern days, it was a great way to revamp any land by using excavation while protecting the vital structures on them.

So, it’s a perfect method to pull out the pieces of tauranga in the foundation.

The project involved digging vertical and horizontal shafts underneath. But that would inevitably sink the palatial foundation. The freezing method could prevent such from happening. Moreover, it could lower the weight being added to the independent pillars when the Taurangas are replaced. That was what Lloyd was after, and it was the product of countless theories, calculations, simulations, and experiments.

So, please! Queen! Your Majesty! Come on, my dear friend! Just this time!

Lloyd desperately hoped that the queen would happily agree and allow him to use a more convenient method for construction. He looked up at the queen with puppy dog eyes.

“Ha.” Scoff escaped Queen Magentano, and she finally shook her head in defeat. “You are truly incorrigible.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd.

“Tsk. I have not granted your request yet.”

“Forgive my impudence, Your Majesty.”

“Sure. You should be sorry. You are shamelessly making such a burdensome and outrageous request. Yet, you also make it impossible for me to refuse your request.”

“Words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Highness.”

“I have not permitted you yet, I said.”

“But Your Majesty, your eyes tell me that you will.”

“You dare to claim to know my intentions?”

“Forgive me, Your Majesty.” Lloyd looked away.

“Tsk. If only I could hit you right now.”

“Your Majesty?” Lloyd immediately looked up.

“Not at all. I whispered my wish out loud, so forget about it. However, I have a question I would like to ask you.”

“I am at your service.” Lloyd hung his head down again.

Queen Magentano asked, “Can you promise me that your project that involves the usage of the Heart of Winter and taking out the tauranga will not harm the imperial family or me?”

“Certainly, Your Majesty,” said Lloyd.

“Good. Then you have my permission.”

“Excuse me...?” Surprised by her immediate approval, Lloyd raised his head. He found her smiling confidently.

“You made a promise, and I shall trust it. Do you need anything more?”

“Certainly not, Your Majesty. However...” said Lloyd, stopping midway.

“However, what?”

“Your immediate approval makes me feel like a bad man...”

“A bad man? That doesn’t sound bad.”

“Excuse me?”

“Never mind. Anyway, you would not have opted to use such a tedious method if your intent was to harm me and the imperial family. I am simply trusting that you have good intentions and won’t go in that direction. So, do leave now. I will persuade the House of Peers.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty.”

At last, he obtained permission from the queen! Lloyd quickly paid his respects, hiding his joy, and left at lightning speed. He was worried that she might change her mind. After he left, Queen Magentano held back her bitter smile.

“Ha.”

Up until a while ago, her office felt like a busy market. But now, it felt desolate and aloof without Lloyd.

“Truly, he is a sly and cunning man.”

She wanted to keep him by her side and put him to the toil for the rest of his life, so she could lay the foundation for the kingdom to last over 1,000 years. But Lloyd didn’t allow himself to be on her palm. And now, it was as good as half losing him as he came to possess powers too great for her to control. Tables have turned now, and she was faced with the danger of being dragged around by him. It was happening at the very moment. She already had a pile of work to take care of, which only grew taller with the addition of Lloyd’s request. It looked like she had a lot to prepare to get a positive consensus from the nobles.

“How dare he put me to work. And yet, he only seeks me when he needs something. He truly is a bad man,” grumbled Queen Magentano.

♣

Ten days passed. It had been a busy time for Lloyd. He had to get ready to freeze the ground. He hired laborers with the help of the queen and put together the materials for the construction. Afterward, he closely measured the spot for the vertical shafts. To get a deeper look, Lloyd mana blasted the ground, selected the areas for the freeze pipes, and designed the plan.

For the queen, the last ten days had been equally busy. She filed a request to use the Heart of Winter for the House of Peers. At first, they expressed dismay because it was for some repairs in the palace. They wondered if it was indeed necessary, even if the repair was urgent and had a direct correlation with the authority of the royal house. They doubted her at first. But as time progressed, the atmosphere of the house changed as each member slowly came around with either persuasion or bribery. The queen's coaxing, flattery, and gifts worked. Eventually, all of them signed the agreement, and a consensus was reached.

At last, the Heart of Winter was transferred to the construction site under the strict management and guard of the royal magicians and knights. Although the marble was a strategic weapon carrying horrifying powers, none of it mattered to Lloyd. He didn't give a rat's ass about its power and danger. It was nothing but a handy tool to freeze the ground. Just like that, the construction to attain the Tauranga began. But Lloyd, Javier, and the other laborers were clueless about something.

Thud! Thud! The Heart of Winter, resting inside a specially designed control chest, was now resonating with Lloyd's heartbeat.

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Chapter 279: A Lucky Accident (1)

Hmm?

Having arrived at the construction site before anyone else in the morning, Lloyd was getting ready for the day when he felt something strange.

What the heck? What's wrong with my heart?

Something felt off. His heart was racing without any particular trigger, and it strangely felt cold, as though someone threw a scoop of ice cream inside him.

What is this?

It wasn't serious, however. Just faint enough for a dull person to miss it. But Lloyd wasn't dull. He owned the manaheart of an intermediate-level sword expert. He detected even the smallest and faintest changes in his heart.

Strange. This has never happened to me.

Lloyd closed his eyes and examined his heart, focusing on his senses. With that, his pounding chest felt even more clear.

So, it's not my heart... It's the manaheart in my heart moving on its own.

His manaheart was moving the cold mana on its own. But that was only for a moment. Right now, the cold energy was going away.

What was that? Should I ask Javier later?

Since Javier was more of an expert than him when it came to the manaheart or the mana circle, Lloyd decided to ask him after today's job.

I kind of want to ask him immediately if I can.

Except that Lloyd couldn't. He was sorry about it. Javier wasn't with Lloyd. He was training with the queen and set to stay there all day as her sparring

partner to help improve her fighting skills.

While I’m asking, I should also get him to inspect my mana circle.

Lloyd put that on his to-do list. The timing was good since he feared that his manaheart skill would increase to a high level and give him sword master syndrome along with horrible insomnia. So, there was a need to get it checked to find out if his manaheart was leveling up without his knowledge.

Insomnia? No, thank you.

His shoulders quivered at the thought, and now, the inexplicable cold sensation in his manaheart was completely gone. A little later, a group of laborers started to arrive at the site one after another.

“You guys are late!” bawled Lloyd when he saw them. “You should come on time to prepare your work tools and join the morning meeting, don’t you think?”

Lloyd’s reproach hastened their steps, and the site immediately bustled with vibrant activities. Lloyd and the laborers began to move around busily. The Heart of Winter inside the control chest did too.

♣

Thump... Thump...

The Winter of Heart was stored in a chest specially designed to control its capacity for construction. And now, it was beating. It was pounding like the heart of a human in the presence of a lover. It was thumping like the person who met their life partner. This resonation was unprecedented and like never before. As it picked up a strange and rare sense of familiarity from a human, it could not help but resonate and vibrate. It aligned its rhythm to the person’s heartbeat.

Its faint ego posited a theory. Perhaps, this was the day its creator, Ice Dragon Tyrannus, had once predicted in the distant past when the

Magentano Kingdom was founded. It wondered if Ice Dragon Tyrannus created it and presented it to the founding king, Mikael, for this reason.

Thump...Thump...

It probably was the case, the Heart of Winter thought. This meeting had to be fate, not a coincidence. How could it be otherwise? This was the first time it had ever met a human whose manaheart possessed similar qualities to that of a dragon. The Heart of Winter never imagined that encountering an entity like this would be possible.

Thud... Thud...

The Heart of Winter quietly quivered in the chest and sent a message to the human's manaheart as it shyly resonated.

♣

Ding dong.

Hmm?

Lloyd had been engrossed in the excavation project. He triple-manablasted the ground to dig the vertical shaft, sent Ppodong to expand and flatten it, and assigned laborers to clear the rocks and dirt before plastering its walls with temporary concrete. He also took part in shoveling and even supervised the whole process. As such, he couldn't focus on anything else. But when a message floated in front of his eyes out of the blue, he stopped.

What is this?

He looked at the message with dismay.

[Manaheart Skill Option ④ : Half-Human Half-Dragon has been activated.]

[Your mana, which coincidentally came to possess the same unique quality seen in a dragon's heart, is attracting the attention of a dragon-like creature. This mysterious dragon-like creature is considerably

curious about you, and one small encounter will be enough for it to shower you with explosive favor.]

What?

Lloyd wiggled his brow.

A dragon-like creature? Something like that is nearby me? And it's even curious about me?

Lloyd hurriedly looked around, but all he could see were the fantastical creatures like Ppodong, laborers, and royal magicians managing and monitoring the chest of the Heart of Winter.

Is there a dragon among them?

Lloyd soon banished the thought.

The message said a dragon-like creature, not a dragon.

So, there was a creature akin to a dragon. The message confused Lloyd, and he had no clue as to what it meant.

Tsk. Things have been strange since earlier.

Something peculiar has been taking place since this morning. His manaheart produced chilly air out of nowhere, and now, a message appeared to tell him that a dragon-like creature was curious about him. None of this had ever happened to him before.

Could it be the Heart of Winter? I don't think so. It's a magical item, so it can't be related to the dragons. Tsk. Oh, whatever.

Unable to find any answer, Lloyd pushed the thought away and decided to focus on his present task. The vertical shaft construction couldn't be done carelessly, so Lloyd figured he should focus on the site before anything else.

Nothing is more dangerous than losing focus at a construction site.

That was the nature of construction sites. Even if everything looked like it was in place and safe, even if you were a seasoned worker with decades of experience, a moment of lost concentration would lead to an accident. Lloyd had witnessed such unfortunate accidents a few times before.

I've seen smaller accidents that resulted in a back or shoulder incident. Otherwise, I saw a grinder blade bounce off as it cut through a block of wood before. The worst accidents are... Well, it happened to the man whose family was abroad... Tsk. Let's not dwell on it.

Lloyd didn't want to continue his sudden thought as it saddened him. Anyway, his point was that construction sites were filled with danger.

We're excavating the vertical shafts.

He was already digging 32 feet under the ground. The plasterers were dangled in the air as they plastered temp concrete on the walls, like the skyscraper window cleaners and painters. Therefore, it was imperative for Lloyd to keep a close eye on the job because they could get hurt otherwise.

Lloyd had the duty to responsibly supervise the progress, his keen eyes never missing anything. As he spent every day, alert and vigilant, focusing on the job, he soon forgot about the message. The construction developed smoothly, and eventually, the shaft's depth reached 147 feet. Next, Lloyd instructed Javier to bore several horizontal holes, about eleven inches in diameter, beside the vertical shaft toward the palace. By this time, Javier had free control over his manablast. He could determine its length and diameter.

"Carefully and position it correctly," instructed Lloyd. "Follow the angle I marked for you. If you swerve even a little, your mana blast will strike or penetrate the piers of the palace. You know that can't happen, right?"

"Of course."

Kaboom! Each time Javier's sword glinted, it produced hundreds of yards-long horizontal holes that passed beneath the palace foundation. After a few days, dozens of such holes were bored. Next, Lloyd inserted customized

metal pipes into some of them and connected one side of each to the refrigerant supply pipe, which was then attached to the Winter of Heart chest. The royal magicians were the ones operating the chest.

Whoosh... Under the magicians' control, the chest reacted and slowly opened up, revealing the Heart of Winter. And it started to emit frigid air, the volume of it kept well under control.

Craaack... Crack! The chilly air produced frost around the chest and the refrigerant supply pipe.

Craaack! The white frost soon spread to the metal pipes at a fast speed and started to harden the moisture inside the soil around the pipes.

Great. Everything's going according to my plan.

Lloyd clenched his fists as he observed the freezing ground with his surveying skill.

The Heart of Winter is really cold. It lives up to its title as a divine treasure of our kingdom.

It wasn't like an ordinary cold freezer. Its temperature was hundreds of degrees in the negative. The amazing part was that Lloyd wasn't employing its full capabilities.

At this rate, I should be able to freeze the entire foundation under the palace within just a few days. Well, theoretically, though, I shouldn't freeze the ground at such rapid speed.

Supposedly, this method was to be conducted slowly due to the way water took up more space when it was frozen. If the ground froze too rapidly, all the moisture in the ground would expand. That would cause the ground to protuberate and considerably damage the structure.

And so, typically, the ground is frozen over several months, as slowly as possible, while ensuring that the protuberation is as controlled as possible. So, it's only done in construction sites that have enough time and space.

But time was a luxury to Lloyd. He didn’t have several months to waste, so he opted for the slightly drastic measure, which was inserting only a handful of pipes for freezing among all the holes Javier had dug.

I left the rest of them empty. That will prevent the ground from being uplifted. The vacant holes will cover the expanded size.

Lloyd did the calculation already. The vacant holes will make up for the holes that will expand once frozen. Thanks to this clever idea, he could freeze the entire palace ground within a few days, and there wasn’t much elevation in the ground. Once Lloyd checked that all was good, he moved on to the next part of the construction.

“Okay!” shouted Lloyd. “Bangul will chomp up the dirt first, followed by Ppodong, who will flatten the ground and follow behind. The rest of you guys will transfer the rocks and dirt. Blacksmiths! What did I tell you to make out of Bangul’s rebars?”

“Rebar fixtures!”

“Yes, indeed. I am sure you’ve familiarized yourselves with the measurements.”

Everyone got to work. Now, they started to dig a horizontal tunnel from the vertical shaft they had dug before, heading toward the palace. As for this, Lloyd utilized the shield method, which he once used to construct the bituminous coal mine back in his fiefdom. This time, however, it was more developed and larger in scale. Everyone became one and energetically excavated the horizontal tunnel, which was designed to be about twenty feet in diameter.

In the process, Lloyd frequently made use of the rebar supports to prevent the tunnel from collapsing, and afterward, he inserted lock bolts on all sides and plastered concrete on them. The concrete played the same role as the short concrete in the New Austrian Tunnelling Method (NATM) by being the additional layer to the tunnel inside. Moreover, the ground around the tunnel was extremely stable because it was frozen. The ice and soil naturally supported the weight surrounding the tunnel. This was also one of

the core principles of NATM. Lloyd's careful consideration and application design created a synergy and ensured the tunnel excavation was smooth sailing. The tunnel's distance increased as a result.

Five days. Ten days. 15 days. Time passed and the tunnel finally reached its destination: 16 feet below the isolated piers where the tauranga was. There, Lloyd altered the direction of the excavation.

This time, we're going upward.

Now, it was time to dig upward from the bottom to the top until they would be able to take out the tauranga from the side of the pillars. Everyone became one in boring the upward tunnel, clearing all the stones and rocks, and flattening and reinforcing the vertical passage. The tunnel moved upward along the isolated piers. And just like that, everyone believed the construction would occur without any accidents. It was stable in everyone's eyes. But on the same morning they started this part of the project, an accident took place. An obstacle nobody foresaw. A lucky accident that would become a key stepping stone to Lloyd's future development.

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Chapter 280: A Lucky Accident (2)

Cesare Di Bergamo, a low-ranking royal magician, was born with a silver spoon in his mouth. Everything used to go well for him. He was born into the family of Marquess Bergamo, who had raised top royal magicians for several generations. He was the fifth son of the family and grew up with host privileges around him. As the rightful son of a noble family set to lead the kingdom and manage many under him, Cesare received an elite education, and his life lacked nothing. As a result, when he became ten, he almost mastered all the basic theories of magic, which earned him the title of a genius.

That was when it hit Cesare. He was a special being. A dignified and important person. He deserved special treatment from others. From then on, he didn't view anyone below him as a human being. They were merely a bunch of subservient vermin, bugs that would lick his shoes at his command.

With that mindset, he enrolled in the royal academy. He continued to receive special treatment there. After all, he was the fifth son of a family that raised top royal magicians. Moreover, they were distantly related to the imperial family. His sixth grandmother had been a royal princess, which meant that divine royal blood flowed in him. Cesare was untouchable in school. The students, housemasters, and professors didn't dare to treat him badly, and even the president of the academy studied the same year with his father. With power on his shoulder that gave him all sorts of privileges, he ruled the roost in the academy. It only took one word from him to get something done. His grade, the way he was treated. Everything. This confirmed something in him again. He was special. Even in a place where noble sons and daughters came to study, he was special. Anyone below him deserved to be treated like vermin.

As such, Cesare pestered the sons of low-ranking nobles. He had no grand reasons for doing so. It was simply amusing to watch them beg and plead before his nose. And Julian Frontera amused him the most. The petite fellow from a remote eastern province provided him with the greatest

entertainment. Unlike the others, who never met him in the eyes after one bullying, Julian's eyes remained alive and spirited. Whatever harassment the vermin received, the next day, he shot back with the same clarity in his eyes. Furthermore, he received good grades at every chance he was given as if he wasn't bullied. To Cesare, Julian was an amusing toy worth destroying to pieces, and so he decided to dial up his bullying by ordering the other lowly students to harass Julian, saying they have to do so until he dies. A hick from a province shouldn't be getting good grades. A man of low birth was better suited to lick his shoes in subservience. The bullying was endless. However, then something happened.

Lloyd Frontera...

The name was stuck in Cesare's head. Lloyd Frontera. The older brother of Julian, his toy. Lloyd ruined everything. After taking Julian out of the academy and buying the trust of the queen by building that weird suspension bridge, the man reported everything to her at the completion event.

He told the queen about Julian's bullies. How those bullies defiled the fair and honorable spirit of the academy. With that came Cesare's downfall. He was the leader of the group of students Lloyd had reported to the queen. The result of this event was merciless. Enraged, the queen expelled Cesare from the academy, and he was forced to keep a low profile in his manor for two years. But those two years felt more like a barless prison.

But what really hurt him was the loss of reputation from high society. He became the black sheep. Even though his status blocked him from more serious punishment, torture, or execution, his honor and future were taken away from him. He was out of the queen's favor. He was stripped of the chance to become a public official and ended up as a laughingstock among the nobles. Even his family looked down on him; his parents never spoke a word to him since the incident. And his brothers and sisters tossed repulsive gazes at him as though he was the embarrassment of the family. Even the servants and maids gossiped behind his back.

How dare you! You're nothing but vermin!

Cesare felt indignant. The treatment he was receiving was unfair. Even when his father pleaded to the queen on his knees for forgiveness, which secured him a low-ranking job as a royal magician, Cesare was terribly embittered about the whole thing. He felt cheated. He was supposed to be special.

Of course! I'm more capable than other magicians! More noble in blood! Yet what? A low-ranking magician?

It was a complete bogus. With his status and power, it was only right for him to be placed as the second most powerful magician from the start. But what happened to Lloyd, who destroyed his life by telling on him to the queen? He was having a streak of success, unbefitting his status!

A meritorious retainer?!

Lloyd was even appointed as a meritorious retainer for suppressing the Bone Dragon. No words came out when Cesare heard the news. No. Even now, he was left speechless.

"Everything all good today?"

It was Lloyd who spoke. Cesare shut his mouth and simply glared at Lloyd with a straight face. Lloyd shrugged back with a faint grin.

"Having a bad morning, I guess? Well, loosen up. Have a good day today," greeted Lloyd nonchalantly.

Cesare couldn't tell if the latter was being brazen or friendly as he greeted him. Lloyd was about to leave the operation room for the Heart of Winter when Cesare spoke as he looked at Lloyd's back.

"Wait, hold on." Quite surprised that he called Lloyd, he impulsively asked, "Do you not know who I am?"

Lloyd turned and stared at Cesare. "I know who you are."

"You do?" Cesare asked in a rude tone.

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded, and in a matter-of-fact voice, he added, “You’re a magician from the palace who manages the Heart of Winter. Hahaha.”

“...”

“Thanks to you, the construction is going smoothly. The Heart of Winter is stably providing cold air. Once this construction is finished, why don’t we have dinner together with everyone else? Have a good day today, then.”

Lloyd innocently greeted him farewell and left the room. Now, Cesare was left alone in the room. There was a flush of uncontrollable rage and shame on his face.

How dare he... not recognize me?

Cesare was utterly dumbfounded. He thought Lloyd would remember and berate him for bullying Julian. But this wasn’t the case.

He doesn’t remember me. It’s all because my life has been ruined, and I’m just a low-ranking magician. On the other hand, things are going superbly for him as a meritorious retainer of the imperial family. How dare he... a mere vermin!

Lloyd did not remember. Even after destroying Cesare’s life, he didn’t recognize him. And as though that was not enough, Lloyd was his superior.

He attained the trust of the queen and became the supervisor for the repair construction of the palace... And I’m here rotting, doing what he tells me to do. Why? Why is that?

Cesare couldn’t wrap his head around it. He was a special person. Someone far too dignified to be rotting down here. He couldn’t erase the thought that something was going wrong with this world. He couldn’t stop thinking that his life was over.

One day, two days, and soon, five days later. His rancor and disappointment increased sizably. And finally, on the day the upward vertical cave construction started, which was the same morning he received another

scornful glance from his brothers, Cesare made a decision as he came to work.

I should die.

But not alone. He'd take Lloyd Frontera with him to Hell and ruin his project, even tainting his reputation in the process. He came to work with such a dark resolution in mind and sought for an opportunity all morning and afternoon. And finally, he made his move.

"Eup…?"

Cesare brought out his dagger, plunged it into the back of his colleague in the room, and covered his mouth. His colleague fell to the floor.

I don't have time.

Six royal knights were outside. Even though they were guarding outside and couldn't hear the noise of his colleague falling because the doors were thick, it would be only a matter of time for them to notice that something was going on inside.

Right now.

Cesare chanted to himself his malicious goal of killing everyone, Lloyd Frontera in particular, and stood before the chest that contained the Heart of Winter. The chest required two royal magicians' magic power to control it, but this wasn't an impossible task for him. Although he was only one person without his colleague, Cesare was a talented magician and could somewhat control it on his own.

Argh...!

Cesare upped the capacity of the chest as much as he could. Beyond its limit. To the point of damaging the chest. There was an immediate reaction.

Whoosh...! The chest made an eerie noise as frost swept over the chest at lightning speed. And Cesare, who was standing in front of it, received the blow without exception.

“...!”

Frigid air, now at its lowest possible temperature, swept his whole body, but he tried to endure it. He couldn’t even let out a scream. A few seconds. That was all he could endure in the face of the Heart of Winter that released its maximally frigid air. And finally, a crack appeared in the chest. Cesare smiled. He realized his time had come.

“What is going on here?!”

The knights shouted as they kicked the door open and entered upon sensing suspicious activity inside. At that moment, the chest went off, causing a chilling explosion in the area.

♣

Baaang!

“Eh...?”

Lloyd abruptly raised his head when he sensed a strange vibration. He had been excavating the vertical cave with an intense focus on his work as it was happening from the bottom up unlike before.

What was that?

It had come from somewhere nearby. Cocking his head to the side, Lloyd judged from the strength and echo of the vibration that it came from the cave’s exit.

It was quite strong. But this shouldn’t be happening near the exit area. I installed enough support for it, and the concrete is well-plastered. I inspected everything. Could it be the Rock Burst phenomenon? No. Judging by the state of the ground, there’s no way.

Lloyd shook his head. The Rock Burst phenomenon referred to when rocks burst out from the sides of a tunnel due to the pressure inside it.

It’s similar to how a pimple pops when you squeeze it.

This was a phenomenon that actually took place in Europe during the construction of tunnels in the Alps. Here, rocks with a diameter of up to seven feet were said to have burst out from the tunnel's walls.

But it's not possible here... It can't happen down here. Then what was that noise?

The noise gnawed at Lloyd, more so because he was in a tunnel, which could crumble even at a tiny crack or sink. Everyone would be in danger if that happened.

Something like that happened when I built the mine for bituminous coal. I was locked inside with Javier when I blasted the methane gas to kill the ants.

But today, he wasn't with Javier. The latter was at the palace after being summoned by the queen, just like any other time. He was currently teaching his sword fighting skills as a grandmaster to the queen.

So, it'll be a big problem if something happens when he isn't around.

Lloyd raised his hand, thinking he ought to check it out, and was about to send a stop signal to the team when...

Whoosh... Cold air traveled from the exit through the tunnel.

Hmm?

Lloyd flinched. Something was off.

What? Why is there cold air blowing down here?

The wind was cold, like the one that blows in the early winter morning. The problem with it was that the wind was blowing into the underground tunnel. It was impossible for this to happen. It was supposed to be hotter down in the tunnel since it was underground.

"Everyone, stop! Stand by here!" The moment Lloyd realized how abnormal the cold wind was, he yelled at the laborers before hurrying

toward the exit.

It's strange. Really. I should check it out.

An ominous feeling crept in him. The strange tremor. The cold wind. As the bad feeling grew worse, his steps became more hurried. And the air grew colder as he sped more, turning into a biting wintry wind blowing in the Arctic area. By this time, Lloyd was already sprinting.

It looks like something happened with the Heart of Winter or the refrigerant supply pipes.

Even though Lloyd didn't want to admit it, the frost on the tunnel walls and the biting wind scratching his skin confirmed his bad feeling. But he didn't stop. Even when his body was covered with frost and when he could see his cold breath, Lloyd dashed toward the source of the freezing air. Something definitely happened to the Winter of Heart. Do nothing, and everyone down in the tunnel will freeze to death. Something must be done. But first, he wanted to check what was going on.

If something really happened to the Heart of Winter, and if that is what's releasing the icy air... What should I do? Get Bangul to use her explosion through the tunnel? Would the heat storm dissipate the cold air? No. If I do that, the explosion pressure could kill them since it's a confined space here.

Lloyd ran as he racked his brain for a solution. At last, he arrived at the room that stored the Heart of Winter, the site of the horrible explosion. It was just then.

Boom! Even before he had the time to see, the cold storm of the Ice Age swept him. Simultaneously, his title effect was activated.

Ding Dong!

[<Frozen Hands, Frozen Feet> has been activated.]

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Chapter 281: My Responsibility (1)

It's cold, Lloyd thought. A gust of icy wind nipped his skin. He opened his eyes wide and saw a message through the swirling ice storm around him.

[<Frozen Hands, Frozen Feet> has been activated.]

"...!"

[You are now in a region where the annual average temperature is under 32 °F. As such, "Frozen Hands, Frozen Feet" has been activated. You will no longer suffer from hypothermia or freeze to death in cold climates.]

"Emph...!" Lloyd choked as he wrapped his hands around his body and thought fast. He thought about the current situation and the message's meaning. Then he realized a potential danger.

The effect is useful... but it's only protecting me from hypothermia. There's no mention of protecting my skin from frostbite.

The moment he realized it...

Ziiing! Lloyd activated the Asrahan Core Technique and started desperately absorbing heat around him, amplifying it into three-strand circles. After loading it into his manaheart, he received a feeling of warmth throughout his skin, lungs, and eyes. It was only then that he was finally able to stand straight.

Woah. That was dangerous.

Hypothermia and frostbite were two entirely different conditions that could result from the freezing cold. The former described nothing short of freezing to death. The latter meant tissue necrosis in the skin.

So, if I blindly trusted my title and didn't do anything, I'd have been able to survive but with frostbite in my ears and fingers. The sudden exposure to

cold air would have dramatically decreased my blood flow, and as a result, my skin tissue would've died because of the lack of oxygen.

This kind of injury from cold, especially on the earflaps, was common among South Korean men while standing guard at the country's border in the military during the middle of winter.

That was close... I'm now saved from getting frostbite and freezing to death. I had no idea the effects could have loopholes. I should be more careful from now on.

Lloyd learned from this experience that he shouldn't blindly trust his title effects. Thinking that in his head, he pulled himself together and looked straight ahead into the rough, swirling storm. At first, his vision was blurry. Everything was vague and hazy. The storm was relentless, and the white snow hellishly blew around him. But when he trudged a few steps forward, his view became clearer.

This is a mess.

The refrigerant room in which the Heart of Winter was stored, protected by thick metal doors and six guard knights, was a mess. The metal doors were crumpled like a soda can and stuck into a corridor wall, along with several sharp shards of ice.

Where's the Heart of Winter?

Lloyd wondered whether the treasure he'd begged to obtain from the queen was safe and whether the people in here were okay. He stepped across the threshold, jittery and anxious, and peered into the room. And he saw...

"Dammit."

Everyone was on the ground and immobile. Two royal magicians and six guard knights were sprawled like mannequins on the floor. But the Heart of Winter was there, fiercely pounding. It was emitting frigid air through the cracks of the broken control chest. In short, it was on a rampage.

I knew that was the problem.

Lloyd's heart pounded. But something was strange. Each time his heart beat, the Heart of Winter squelched and released more cold air.

What the heck? Is it reacting to my Half-Human Half-Dragon skill option?

It appeared so. Lloyd was initially skeptical, but when he took a closer look, that was the case. Plus, it looked like the burst of air it released grew rougher as he neared. It was like a wild beast leaping around in joy to meet its master.

What's going on?

Lloyd bit his bottom lip. Now wasn't the time to investigate. It didn't matter if this object was matching the beat of his heart or reacting to his optional skill. Right now, there was a crisis to solve.

That's a national treasure. How should I compensate for it if it gets destroyed? And what about the laborers inside? Let's think. Think...

Come hell or high water. The situation had to be controlled. He had to do something. Anything. But Lloyd had no clue about how he could silence the out-of-control Heart of Winter. He felt stuck.

I wish Javier was with me.

Lloyd wondered how different things would be if Javier were here. After all, he was a grandmaster who possessed a monstrous manaheart and matching mana capabilities. He was the main protagonist of the original storyline in the novel. But Lloyd knew his wish was futile. Javier wasn't here. He was currently at the palace training with the queen.

I can only take this matter into my own hands.

A thought crossed his mind: this was a battle of time. The longer he let this incident progress, the harder the situation would be to resolve. Just then...

"Argh... Ah..."

Lloyd picked up an ever so faint, agonized groan. It was coming from one of the royal guard knights on the floor.

Eh? Is someone alive?

Lloyd studied the groaning guard in surprise. To his astonishment, the man was breathing, though very faintly. His skin and lips were blue, and his pulse was faint from his severe hypothermia. But he was alive and holding on.

What about the others?

Lloyd jumped to his feet and checked the others. And he uttered, “Almost everyone is alive.”

Except for one person, who was the closest magician to the Heart of Winter, carrying a bloody dagger. The rest of them were breathing but on the brink of death.

It’ll be difficult for all of them to survive if this goes on for much longer.

The realization compelled him to immediately grab the six knights and one magician out to the corridor one by one. He first hoisted up the magician, who appeared to be in the most critical state. The man was bleeding in the back from an injury that looked to be from a dagger. However, the bleeding strangely wasn’t severe, and Lloyd figured it was probably because the wound had frozen during the explosion of frigid air in the room.

It looks like the dead magician stabbed him.

Lloyd frowned, his forehead crinkling, thinking what event could have possibly taken place in here. But he knew now wasn’t the time to dwell on such curiosity.

I’ve got to hurry.

There were people who needed to be saved. Lloyd focused all his efforts on rescuing them without missing a beat, first by carrying the magician on his

back and transferring heat into the man’s major organs through the Asrahan Core Technique. And he climbed the vertical shaft toward the cave exit.

“Here! Call a doctor. Quickly!”

Lloyd shouted as he made it out on the ground. Just in time, there was a group of laborers near the exit. They were nervously chatting among themselves about the explosion and the strange gusts of cold air coming from inside the cave.

“Did something happen inside?”

“Yeah. An accident. There is cold air leaking from the Heart of Winter. Call for a doctor immediately.” Lloyd then looked at the leader of the group, who just spoke. “There are more people down there. I’ll get them out. Call a doctor and inform the queen. Get some blankets to warm all the bodies. As many as you can. And this guy over here has a stab wound. Press down against it firmly until a doctor gets here.”

“Yes.” There was nervousness in his eyes.

The rest of the laborers in the group became busy with their tasks. Meanwhile, Lloyd sprinted back to the cave and got down the ladder. He then carried one of the knights in the corridor on his back, dashed away, climbed the ladder, and laid him under the warm sun. He then left the others to care for him and went back in. Lloyd repeated this trip six times. Eventually, Lloyd managed to save everyone. Thankfully, everyone lived, likely due to how the knights were well-trained and strong.

“Ha... Whew...”

Lloyd’s body gave way to exhaustion as soon as he rescued everyone to safety. Calming his breath under the warm early summer sun, he dropped to the soiled ground and threw his head down in between his knees. People were running around in hurry and alarm, and yet, despite the chaos around him, the position offered him a dazing warmth. The sunlight stroking his back couldn’t feel any sweeter. He felt warm, cozy, and relieved. And then he flinched.

What the heck am I doing here? Why am I feeling relieved already? There are twenty guys down there... in the deepest part of the cave.

Gulp. Absentmindedly, Lloyd swallowed dryly. How could they have slipped from his mind? Or was he pretending to have forgotten them?

I told them to be on standby while I go and see what happened. I told them to stay low since it's dangerous. I left them there like that.

Lloyd wondered if the impending arrival of the rescue team and the idea of transferring his responsibility to someone else were the source of his irrational relief as he sat on the warm ground under the sunlight.

Should I be the one to go and save them?

A thought came to him. It'd be too late by the time the rescue team arrived. The frigid air would spread all the way to the end of the cave, and they'd be in danger unless he did something then and there.

They won't stay alive until the rescue team can come.

He had to get down there pronto and get them out. That was the right thing to do. He knew that. But at the same time, he was hesitant. Frankly, he was nervous.

Although I won't die as I have the title... It doesn't mean the icy air won't hurt me. Or that it isn't dangerous.

He just carried seven guys out. That added up to seven roundtrips. Each trip made him feel like his whole body was frozen, no, like he was thrown into an icy field naked in the middle of the winter. His skin, from head to toe, was in intense pain like he was being ripped apart. It was even the case when he had the Asrahan Core Technique activated to its full capacity. Plus...

I'll have to go much further down to get to where the laborers are.

The longer travel time meant getting more exposure to the frigid air, giving him an equal amount of pain. He could end up suffering even with the

Asrahan Core Technique. The constant exposure to the air could freeze his ears, face, fingers, and toes until they turned black. His fingers and toes could have to be amputated, like those of the frostbitten hikers of Mount Everest. Even if that didn't happen, his lungs could get injured too. That meant his ability to breathe would be permanently impaired for the rest of his life. All the possibilities he could think of brought him uncertainty and anxiety.

I'm not confident about my safety.

There was a greater chance of his worries coming true. And honestly, Lloyd didn't want that to happen in the slightest.

I'll be disabled for the rest of my life. The rescue team should be coming soon, anyway. Is there really a need for me to risk myself?

It was selfish to think so. Yes, he knew that. But deep down and for just a second, he was hesitant. Nervous. He wasn't a hero in an epic tale nor someone with a strong spirit that couldn't be broken by anything. He was just an ordinary man and wanted to keep it that way for the rest of his life. He was scared.

But at the same time, he was being bugged by a memory from his period of destitution. The days when he was living in a room rental in South Korea and worked tirelessly every day on construction sites. The most wretched, infuriating memory of his from then pestered his mind.

There was a middle-aged man at the construction site he worked at. He and Lloyd bumped into each other a few times at the employment agency and worked as a team from time to time. But Lloyd didn't know the man's name. They weren't very close and merely had some chats over a few meals. Lloyd thought of him as nothing more than just a slightly pitiful older man.

He said he was a goose father.

The man's story went like this: He was a manager in a well-to-do corporation. Financially sound, he sent his daughter to the United States to

study along with his wife as he was nervous about sending the former alone. He lived as a goose father for a few years.

But one day, he got laid off. Unable to break the news to his family because he feared worrying them and affecting the child's studies, he endured the pain of his abrupt retirement alone. That was when he switched gear to construction sites. He didn't tell his family about it. Since suddenly starting a business came with the risk of losing his severance pay and he had family members to feed in the US, he started to work in construction sites, drenching himself in sweat, while his severance pay was squirreled away.

How the man laughed while saying that doing physical labor suited him better than being at a desk all day.

He was a good-tempered man despite his pitiful circumstances. His humor involved a lot of dad jokes, to Lloyd's discomfort. However, he was a good man with a bright smile. That was Lloyd's entire impression of him. After all, he was as pitiful as this one. So Lloyd had some compassion for him but thought no more beyond that.

But that same afternoon, the man fell. An accident happened which took away his ability to walk for the rest of his life. Yet how did people react at the construction site? Business continued as usual. As if nothing happened. As if the man was just a broken component being replaced. The site returned to operation as though nothing happened. Lloyd was dumbstruck. He couldn't wrap his head around it.

What really struck me even more dumb was the supervisors at the scene.

In the first place, the construction site had been poorly managed and lacked safety protocols. The accident could have been prevented if proper safety net regulations were put in place. But in spite of that, none of the supervisors were willing to take responsibility for what happened. Instead, the blame was put on the man for being careless. They made pathetic excuses for themselves, giving out all kinds of excuses for their wrongdoings, and merely provided a little money for his medical expenses and compensation pay. No one offered the man a proper apology or

reimbursement for the accident. What did Lloyd think after seeing the whole incident unfold?

Dirty. Filthy.

The same emotions he felt that day arose in him again. How enraged and indignant he had felt when the supervisors refused to take responsibility. How wretched and cheated he had felt, even when he wasn't the victim. And now?

I'm just like them.

His last train of thought immediately propelled him to leap to his feet. A pang of repulsion came over him as he recalled how he was mere minutes ago, comfortably perched on the ground under the warm sun while making a preposterous excuse that the rescue team would come and save the workers.

If that's how it is, then I'll be no different than the supervisors I had berated at the time.

He didn't like that. This was his construction site. A job he obtained from the queen. He was responsible for it as the supervisor. And now that an accident took place at his site, even though it wasn't his fault that it happened, it happened. And who was supposed to take responsibility for it?

Me.

Lloyd was the man in charge. At least for this work site, he was. And no one could take his place. No one could take on his responsibility for him.

This is my duty.

Before he knew it, he was running. He rushed into the break room and took all the thin blankets and large-sized overalls inside before running back to the cave entrance. He was about to jump right down when he was stopped by the group leader.

"Master Lloyd? You are not... going down there, are you?"

“I am.” It was obvious that he should. There was no time to dawdle around here. He spat, “Winter blankets. Coats. Get as many as you can. Hurry up. And give an accurate report of the situation to the rescue team once they arrive.”

“I understand your instructions,” the leader reasoned hurriedly, “But it’s going to be dangerous down there. The rescue team will be here soon anyway. What do you plan to achieve by personally going down there alone?”

“What else?”

The decision was already made. Lloyd knew what he had to do. Thinking so, he stared at the group leader and replied in the most nonchalant manner, “I have to save them. Everyone.”

There was nothing left to say and no more time to waste. Just like that, Lloyd jumped into the vertical shaft.

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Chapter 282: My Responsibility (2)

Fwoosh! A flash of light dropped straight down at lightning speed with a thundering roar. It aimed for his head, but Javier reacted with nonchalance.

His foot took a half step to the side, avoiding the blow by the edge of a knife, and he held out his sheath simultaneously. *Swish.*

A slow, relaxed stab. It was a simple attack, so common that one would yawn at the sight of it. But Queen Magentano panicked when she received his counterattack.

“Hmph!” Her eyes widened in fright as his sheath dominated her vision.

He’s blocking all the directions around him.

Even though Javier had his sheath extended toward her abdomen, she noticed the various changes to its motion. She felt it. She sensed it. She may attempt another blow, but the sheath would change the path and neutralize her. Thus, her next move should be to retreat and avoid it.

Tsk!

The queen quickly stepped back, pulling her sword back and adding flexibility to it.

Whoosh! Fwish! Her sword glinted as it rotated twice in front of her, and a ray of red aura appeared in its glint. Seven strands of the aura extended like a whip and wrapped Javier’s sheath. No, it almost did but failed.

Slash! The sheath instantly disappeared. The seven strands of the queen’s aura were wrapped around nothing but empty air. Javier’s sheath vanished before she could even respond to its stabbing.

“...!”

Queen Magentano’s eyes trembled for a second. Just then, she heard Javier’s voice from her left.

“Your Majesty’s counterattack against mine was sharp and quick. It was excellent. However, if I may point out a potential point of improvement, You Majesty still has the tendency of overreacting to your opponent’s movements and relying on your technique.”

“Argh!”

She didn’t notice him coming from the side. Astonished, she yanked her aura to the side, and it splashed so powerfully to grind any material in its way. The violence of her aura enveloped Javier’s whole body. And yet, he looked composed. His sheath moved with equal composure.

“It goes the same now, Your Majesty. If I were you...”

Thud! Twang! Boom! His sheath moved smoothly and with ease as if it was just swaying fruit flies away. All seven strands of her aura bounced off at his movement. The more amazing part was that Javier’s sheath was bare. It didn’t have anything that remotely resembled an aura. He went on to instruct, “I would have responded like this, Your Majesty.”

Fwoosh! With that, Javier’s ordinary sheath transformed into a calamity. It was like a sweeping tsunami ready to engulf everything in its proximity.

I’m going to die.

That was what the queen’s instincts told her. She felt frightened. Slicing? Stabbing? Striking? Words fell short of describing his blow. “Pulverize” would be the most fitting word if she had to put a name to it. And yet, she didn’t let herself be intimidated. She instead reacted with greater ferocity.

“Argh...!”

She pulled back the seven strands of her aura and compounded them into one, summoning a giant, sword-shaped aura. She confronted Javier’s sweeping blow head-on, and the two overwhelming powers collided.

Boom! A shock wave swept the whole area. Queen Magentano stood her ground, so desperately and earnestly, to win and save herself from being shoved and flung away. She fully opened her manaheart, squeezing out all the strength in her body, and at last, she managed to endure his attack.

“Excellent, Your Majesty. Once you master the movement of your senses and instincts instead of your techniques, you will be able to progress further.”

The storm subsided. The tsunami disappeared. The chaotic space of oppressive sword auras quietened. And now, with the impact of the auras all gone, she saw Javier grinning with a glow of satisfaction. His sheath was still touching her sword. At that moment, something came to her.

She realized that she would never be able to surpass this man, even if she gave her best throughout her life. She wondered if this was what it felt like to be stuck in the presence of a genius. But she, too, often received compliments for being a genius. Could it be that there was another level of genius among geniuses?

This is too unfair.

A bitter smile appeared on her face. But she didn’t allow herself to wallow in self-hatred and shame.

If I can’t surpass him, then I only have to strive to be like him.

And eventually, her path would appear. She didn’t need to work hard to become better than him. It would be enough for her to focus on taking her own path. That was how she would find life’s answers and destinations that solely belonged to her. As such, now was the time for blood, sweat, and tears. Not comparisons.

“What impudence,” said Queen Magentano. “I will worry about how I will progress further. Focus on keeping a hold of your sheath.”

Clatter! She pushed her sword forward. Javier happily fought back. And at the same time, he was amazed.

Her Majesty has completely surpassed the level of an ordinary sword master.

She wasn't this strong back then when she went up against the Bone Dragon. Recently, as Javier helped her train, he got the feeling that her growth speed was no joke.

People often think that being a sword master is the end goal for all sword users.

No, she had surpassed that. The level of a grandmaster was only a theoretical concept. As such, it was widely believed by the public that a sword master's development couldn't be furthered after this stage. This contributed to the custom of comparing the period of one's sword master status to decide who was stronger. The years of being the sword master and operating the aura sword, people normally decided which sword master was stronger based on them. But the queen... She was different. She was like himself. Beyond the evaluation and consciousness of the public.

She is still developing and at a fairly fast speed, too.

The pure obsession and passion over the sword. The belief that her development translated to the growth of the kingdom's military power. Javier wondered if those were the secrets behind her remarkable advancements.

Then I shall help her as much as I can.

Javier resolved inwardly that he'd help her. He wouldn't change his mind even if she surpassed him. And if she did become stronger than him, he'd gladly congratulate her for it. With such resolution in his head, he parried her sword. Just then...

"..."

A strange sound of an explosion came from somewhere. It came from a distance. Inside the cave. Near the construction site Lloyd was supervising. Confusion rushed through Javier.

Could it be a mana blast?

He thought so at first. Could it be that Master Lloyd used the mana blast? But did he have any reason to bore a hole? But soon, he concluded that couldn’t be it.

It sounded different from a mana blast.

The explosion sounded much stranger, and his senses mysteriously picked up on a cold sensation. Despite the long distance, Javier could feel it without a doubt. There was a strange, destructive flow of mana coming from somewhere. It was strange and also dangerous. Javier immediately withdrew his sheath.

“Forgive me, Your Majesty,” said Javier solemnly to the queen.

“Eh...?”

Thwack! The queen was shoved forward when Javier suddenly pulled away his sheath.

Quickly finding her balance, she said, “Forgive you? What do you mean? For what?”

“I have to make an urgent visit, Your Majesty.”

“Urgent visit?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. It appears that something has happened to Master Lloyd. I will provide a better apology after I return. Please excuse me.”

“Hold on!-”

The queen cried out in a hurry, but Javier was already gone. She was left alone.

“What is this...”

She was flustered. How could he vanish in thin air when the training was going well? Without her permission? But it wasn’t something she’d become angry over. She didn’t even berate Javier’s rudeness. Instead, a look of worry came over her face.

He said that something appeared to have happened to Lloyd.

Could it be that Javier felt something she didn’t? Could it be that his grandmaster-level senses detected there was danger looming over Lloyd?

“Sir Maldini!” Something was wrong. She called the commander of the royal knights. “Declare martial law across the capital within the next hour. All citizens are to stay in their homes or a designated evacuation site. All knights and military forces should be prepared for an emergency alert”

“Your Majesty...?” Sir Maldini, the commander of the royal knights, reacted in a daze, possibly because the order came too suddenly. But the queen paid no attention to his timid response.

“Effective immediately. And as for you, lead the royal guards and get to the excavation site for the palace repair. As quickly as possible.”

Javier had fled immediately with a pale look on his face. That was proof of how serious this matter was. As such, she couldn’t just sit back. Once she uttered the order, she leaped and started to make her way to the construction site.

♣

Whoosh! Lloyd’s body dropped down as if he was on a bungee jump and also relentlessly like a waterfall. He was diving into the bottom of the shaft. His eyes glinted.

Now!

He held up his shovel and stabbed it into the air.

Claaack! The shovel's head sparked as it scratched the wall until his drop speed slightly decreased. And his outstretched hand got a grip of the ladder.

Chuck! Although his shoulder jerked at the sudden weight of his body, he was overall fine. He was able to endure it well enough, and it wasn’t the time to let such a menial pain strain him. He then threw his body into the corridor and started to run as soon as he landed.

“Ha! Ha! Ha!”

The air was frigid. Lloyd could feel his body temperature drop. He wondered how cold this place was. Minus 22? 55? Or worse? He didn’t know. His face and hands felt numb even when he was protecting his skin with the Asrahan Core Technique. In particular, the pain became the worst when he moved past the refrigeration room where the Heart of Winter was.

Arggh!

Is this what it feels like to wrap his whole body with liquid nitrogen? Lloyd ran through the thick cloud of frigid air which was determined to paralyze his body. He went further into the end part of the cave, where the laborers were.

“S-S-S-ir... L-L-Loyd? Wh-what... I-Is going... O-O-On?” The leader of the group, whose face was now pale as a sheet, asked as he stuttered. There was fear on his face. Lloyd felt relieved when he saw him.

Thank goodness.

They were alive. Everyone was holding up somewhat. Lloyd quickly scanned his surroundings and realized the secret behind their survival despite the lethally cold temperature.

It’s because of Ppodong.

Ppodong had all twenty of them in his embrace, protecting them with his size and fluffy hair. It was all thanks to him that they didn’t freeze to death. The same went for Bangul.

“Bangul! Bba-bangul! Bangul!”

Bangul, having no fur to warm her, was tightly stuck to Ppodong as she shivered from head to tail. The sight immediately flooded his heart with remorse.

I’m sorry. I got scared and nervous about coming here for a moment.

He had hesitated for a second. Had second thoughts about coming down here. Apologetic, he encouraged, “Have you been waiting for long? It’s all right. Everything is going to be all right.”

“Ppodong!”

“Bangul!”

“And mister,” Lloyd called the leader of the group. “I’m sure you’re very surprised, but you should know what happened.”

Lloyd briefly walked him through what had happened. A look of shock appeared on the leader of the group. “Are... w-w-we g-going to d-d-die then...?”

“No, that will never happen,” said Lloyd adamantly.

“Tt-then...”

“We have to get out of here. We must hurry. However, we’ll never safely make it past the refrigeration room if we try to go out all at once. So I will carry you one by one.”

“...”

“Don’t worry,” Lloyd comforted. “Don’t look at me like that. Can’t you see how I’m fine despite the fact I came all the way here? Hey, over there. You look the worst out of everyone. Come over here, please. Here, cover yourself with this blanket. And put on the overall. Quickly. I brought the biggest one.”

Lloyd then carried one of the men in Ppodong’s embrace and activated the Asrahan Core Technique at the same time, sharing most of his warmth with

the man on his back.

Argh.

As soon as some heat left his body, his skin ached as if they were being lacerated. But Lloyd kept moving.

It's okay. It's just pain. I just have to save enough mana to keep me from getting frostbitten. I won't die. I have my title with me.

He endured his pain with such belief. And hiding his now bluish lips, he smiled at Ppodong.

"Ppodong," called Lloyd.

"P-Ppodong!"

"I'll be right back. Keep embracing them until I come back. Bangul, too."

"Ppodong!"

"Bangul!"

Lloyd jumped into action as he heard their response. There was no time to waste. Stalling any longer would only put them in more serious jeopardy. He needed to hurry.

I can do it!

Lloyd ran. But at the same time, he was sorry that he couldn't use Bangul's Volcanic Explosion.

There's only one way out and in for this cave. If I use the volcanic explosion thoughtlessly, the cave will collapse from the sudden change of pressure. Even if it remains intact, people won't. They'll be receiving the full blow of the explosion in this compact space.

Busted gut. Instant death. As such, Lloyd eliminated the option to use the Volcanic Explosion against the coldness from the list.

This is the only method I've got. It's going to be too late by the time the rescue team gets here.

Lloyd sprinted as he resolved such, passing the refrigerant room. Lloyd could feel that the man was terribly shivering. His back, his arms. The more Lloyd felt him shivering, the more warmth he shared with the man. And this made Lloyd feel colder.

Argh...!

It was as if his whole body was being slashed by a knife. As if his ears were being torn. Even then, he kept running. Past the refrigerant room until he arrived at the bottom of the vertical shaft. He clambered up the tunnel through the ladder, which felt tediously long, and finally walked out to the ground. Lloyd then carefully placed the man down.

"Here! Blankets! Now!"

The men on the ground rushed to the man. Lloyd immediately turned back when he saw them come, leaving the sunlight and throwing himself down to the vertical shaft again. Past the refrigerant room. Into the end of the cave. He carried another man on his back, shared his warmth, and endured the frigid air until he reached the ground again. He passed the man to the others, only to fling himself back into the cold. This process repeated itself.

Three. Four. Five. The longer he withstood the cold, the more lives he saved. And yet, his body started to drain at lightning speed. The Asrahan Core Technique needed to be running in full swing, so he could share the heat and protect the man on his back. Every bit of mana in his manaheart had to be squeezed, so he could give it to the man. That was the only way an ordinary man could survive amid the terrorizing cold. And Lloyd was glad to do it.

But it came with a price. Since he had to give most of his mana to the others, he had to rely solely on his physical muscle and stamina to carry an adult man, run through the stifling cave, and climb the deep vertical shaft. First, he rescued one magician and six knights. Then, the laborers. Lloyd

carried, ran, and climbed with big men on his back. In a severe condition that was rougher than the Arctic Ocean.

Huff, huff! “Ha...!”

Soon, the color started to drain from his face. Beads of sweat froze before they could fall to the ground. Even the act of removing those ice particles burdened him. Lloyd bit his lips.

A little more.

He couldn’t give up just because he was tired. This accident took place at the site he was in charge of. So, everyone’s safety was his responsibility. He must be responsible till the end. Lloyd mechanically sprinted again and again with that thought alone. He even used the Energizer and Latent Power Surge, which eventually got him to save 19 men. And now, only one more was left. He was passing the refrigerant room to save the leader, the last man, when he reached his limit.

Just a little more effort is all I need.

But his legs refused to move. Even when the Asrahan Core Technique was still on the energy conservation mode, his stamina had plummeted. His body was fighting against him. His legs didn’t budge.

Dammit. Please. Just a bit more...

Lloyd whacked his thighs, begging them to move just a little more. Just one last. Ppodong and Bangul can be downsized and carried out. Lloyd hit again and again, pleading and praying they would budge. And each time he did so, his heart pounded and thumped.

Boom! Boom!

The rampageous Heart of Winter thumped violently, matching Lloyd’s desperate heartbeat. And now, the Heart of Winter opened its eyes as it felt Lloyd’s existence with greater clarity. A thought crossed its mind. *Why not become one with the human?*

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Chapter 283: How to Freeze Time (1)

Whoosh... The Heart of Winter had been created by Ice Dragon Tyrannus sometime long ago and presented to the House of Magentano as a gift. But it always considered itself unfortunate. Possessing overwhelming power and capabilities, it was soon locked inside a corner of the palace's repository, away from the sun, never allowed to enjoy the outside world. As such, it was unhappy. It wanted to be treated like any other ordinary piece of treasure. If that had been the case, it wouldn't have been tortured and imprisoned for tens of thousands of years. But it was in this predicament due to its faint consciousness and self-awareness. It felt stifled, yearned for freedom, and sought its chance. And finally, today, it found one.

Whoosh... Bathump! Bathump! The one-inch marble vibrated at a regular beat in excitement after having found the being that would unlock its shackles and free it to the outside world. This human had been drawing its interest for the past few days as the man held a heart that resembled that of a dragon's. As such, the Heart of Winter was curious and interested in him. And today, its emotions developed into adoration. The man had been enduring the cold gusts of air blowing at him all day, and the sight propelled a greedy thought in the Heart of Winter – *Why not become one with that human?* As soon as that thought crossed its mind...

Whoosh... It began to emit frigid air with even more vigor than before, sending every bit of it on Lloyd. It meant to subdue Lloyd, dominate his heart, and steal his body. It would borrow his body and attain freedom. The icy storm, so indescribable and cruel, charged toward the man. Thanks to that, Lloyd felt like he was at death's doorstep.

Ackk!!!!

Lloyd panicked. He was exhausted after having moved one magician, six knights, and nineteen burly men out of the cave. The trip out even involved climbing up a 147-foot ladder while carrying each of them on his back.

It was no wonder he was exhausted. He gave almost all his mana to the people he carried on his back through the Asrahan Core Technique, leaving

barely enough for him to use. His brute muscle strength and endurance were the only things he could rely on to conduct the rescue, so his wobbly legs were about to give way anytime soon. That was when the situation went south as he was met with a storm of ice.

Dammit! Why is it getting colder?!

A pang of alarm rushed through his heart. His stomach dropped like a heavy pack of ice on the floor. Just then, a thought flashed across his mind. He was going to die if he didn't do anything now.

I can't faint here.

Lloyd bit his lips. Of all the places, he had to be right in front of the refrigeration room. What bad luck. It was the closest place to the rampageous Heart of Winter and the coldest area in the entire whole cave. What if he lost strength, fell to the ground, and passed out here? What would happen?

I'll be done for.

The worst-case scenario flashed through his exhausted mind.

I'll be exposed to the freezing cold while I'm knocked out. I won't die, still. I won't get hypothermia or freeze to death. I have the effect with me. But will I be okay? No. Of course I won't.

His whole body would be frostbitten from the hours of exposure to the icy air. In particular, his face and hands, which were not protected by clothes, would take the biggest hit.

My skin will freeze and be ruined. The same goes for the muscles underneath. And all that tissue will necrotize.

In no exaggeration, his skin would rot. He would be left with comprehensive and serious skin damage. As a result, it would give him permanent, untreatable side effects.

I don't want that.

Lloyd shuddered. He could end up needing his hands chopped off. His face would be completely ruined. In all seriousness, he could really be left to live in hellish pain as he suffered from various side effects from his skin injury if things turned for the worse.

That can't happen.

Lloyd shook his head, striving to pull himself together. But it turned out to be harder than he wanted it to be. His depleted stamina and mana. The Asrahan Core Technique that was in energy conservation mode. None of it could help him. And his consciousness continued to fade until his knees eventually crumpled. He reached out his hands, fighting for his life. He touched the ground. At that moment...

"Ouch...!"

His right palm ached, and when he reflexively flinched, he noticed his palm was red with blood.

"..."

Could it be that he was pierced by an ice shard? However, the pain cleared his mind for a second, and he realized something.

This could be my last chance.

Soon, he was certainly going to lose consciousness again amidst the raging ice storm. He'd fade away until he completely passed out. That wasn't something he could allow to happen.

I need to do something. Anything.

Lloyd made a judgment. He then calculated, predicted, decided, and put it all into action.

Ding dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option ⑤: Supercharge has been activated.]

[You will randomly absorb a large amount of mana from your surroundings.]

Lloyd activated his Supercharge. He clenched his teeth.

This is the best I can do right now.

Lloyd was convinced that the Supercharge skill, which let him absorb mana from his surroundings like a blackhole, would suck in large amounts of the frigid air being emitted by the Heart of Winter.

Then, the cold air that's absorbed will have an effect on my manaheart or my circle. Just as it has until now. Similar to when it stole mana from the queen, undead Mastodons, Hell's Knight, and the Bone Dragon. A new skill option will appear, and it'll give me more parameters to work with.

His new parameters would be helpful for him. No, even if it didn't, he didn't care.

At least, my empty manaheart will be full.

Supercharge. This would get his empty manaheart to restore itself again. And he'd be able to recharge himself and revitalize his worn-out muscles. It would allow him to squeeze out enough strength to save Ppodong, Bangul, and the group leader.

So... Please, work!

Lloyd wished for it with all of his heart. With that wish, his consciousness fell into a trance-like state and faded away as his three-strand mana circle began to roar away. *Ziiiiing!*

A swirling storm of mana formed around him, and it soon started to devour all the mana nearby. It absorbed everything it could. The concrete floor, the lock bolts, and the rocks surrounding the area. The ice storm was no exception.

Whoosh... At the sudden change of events, the Heart of Winter wondered in shock if the man had finally lost it. It had sent the ice storm to the man to

steal his heart, only to have him actively absorb the storm. The Heart of Winter wondered if death was indeed what he wanted. But soon, it learned that wasn't the case.

Bzzt...

It turned out that the human was absorbing and processing the cold air for his own use, digesting the mana loaded in the air and recharging his manaheart.

Bzzt!

The Heart of Winter broke into a fit of laughter. This human was getting more interesting the more it learned about him. At the same time, it pitied him. It was like a giant in the presence of a child trying to defend himself with a toothpick. Even though Lloyd was desperately absorbing the cold air, the amount he was taking in was quite insignificant. It was like trying to scoop up a giant iceberg with a single spoon.

Amused, the Heart of Winter decided to dance to his tune. Let him try as much as he wanted. Let him absorb as much air as his heart desired. It proceeded to produce a much more powerful ice storm. The volume of it easily surpassed what Lloyd could take in. The result was destructive.

Bzzt!! Whoosh... Whoosh! Lloyd's body was soon covered with frost. His skin started to freeze, and his exposed face and hands started to develop frostbite. The cold air that his Supercharge failed to absorb began to damage his skin. It was a devastatingly pitiful fight. No, it wasn't even a fight. It was a futile effort of resistance. A hopeless struggle, a protest that was bound to fail. And just like that, Lloyd's whole body was wrapped together with frost and ice. It was around the time when his lower torso was confined by a pillar of ice that Javier arrived.

"Master Lloyd...?"

Javier, who managed to break through the cold and get to the bottom of the cave, was flabbergasted. He was in the middle of training with the queen when he left her to arrive here. A sense of dread had gripped him the entire

time he made his journey. He immediately rushed to the cave after hearing a brief explanation of the situation. He wished and prayed for the fake Lloyd's safety.

"..."

But when he arrived, he found Lloyd half stuck in the ice pillar. He immediately learned what was going on.

It'll be hopeless if this continues.

The Asrahan Core Technique allowed him to see the flow of events that occurred and enabled him to feel the mana absorption in Lloyd. Javier learned that Lloyd was aggressively absorbing mana around him. But there was too much mana for Lloyd to suck in. That was why he was losing and being trapped by the cold air he couldn't absorb.

When Javier realized that, he walked forward without delay into the Supercharge range. And he made himself the target.

Boom! A large volume of mana started to leak from Javier's manaheart from all of his cells. And yet, he didn't mind. He simply responded with his Asrahan Core Technique, reversing the rotation of his three-strand circle and altering the flow of Lloyd's Supercharge. This allowed him to be unaffected by the mana absorption. But Javier didn't stop there.

He took one more step toward Lloyd and reached out and touched Lloyd's shoulder. Closing his eyes, he focused on his manaheart, waking his three-strand mana circle and jumping onto Lloyd's mana circle flow. And just like that, Javier and Lloyd's mana circles were connected, and they started to go wild. Javier's three strands. Lloyd's three strands. Now, there was one six-strand mana circle. It began to rotate, resonate, and amplify. The effect was three times three. In total, the amplification of nine strands. The explosive vitality and overwhelming absorption began to shred, tear, and devour everything.

Ziiing! Now, the absorption had reached a new height of strength. It was the Supercharge of the nine-strand mana circle. Adding to that, Javier took one

more step and touched Lloyd’s back, this time connecting his manaheart to Lloyd’s. Lloyd’s intermediate-level manaheart in his chest, and Javier’s grandmaster-level manaheart made of 60 trillion cells. One big lump. Separated into 60 trillion pieces. The two contrasting manahearts synced, linked, and responded until they eventually formed a multi-manaheart system. The new system assisted the nine-strand mana circle. It digested and purified the mana from the Supercharge and made it into his own. One by one. Like filling up an empty barn. Without a single drop of mana missed. Faithfully yet violently. Ferociously but meticulously. It dominated, conquered, and reigned. Meanwhile, Javier thought to himself...

I do not understand you.

His gaze traveled to Lloyd’s back. Lloyd didn’t respond to Javier’s touch and help as he was in a trance. Lloyd. The eldest son of the Frontera family. However, he was a fraud. An intruder from another world. Despite that, he was the sole pillar holding up the family. The only source of hope that could save the count and countess from the impending disaster. It was the reason why Javier was willingly helping him at the moment.

What you think about the family, the lord, and about me. I cannot tell if you are using us. Whether that is why you have been hiding your identity this entire time. I do not know the answer to anything. However...

However... Javier had only one wish.

I hope I won’t come to regret the countless number of times I made the decision to help you in the past and in the present.

Javier focused his mind more. He concentrated every bit of his strength on the mana circle and manaheart now linked with Lloyd. Lloyd, too, instinctively responded to Javier by absorbing and devouring everything. He didn’t care if the Heart of Winter was a divine item or an artifact created by a dragon. He simply absorbed, devoured, possessed, and conquered. And eventually, the Heart of Winter began to lose out to the tyrannous Supercharge.

Whoosh...

The Heart of Winter vibrated with more consistency, intrigued to meet the human capable of suppressing it. This human had been piquing its interest for days now because he carried a heart akin to a dragon's heart. But now, its interest developed into feelings of admiration.

Even though he was receiving help from another person, it was he who was devouring its ice storm. And a new impulse came over it: What about becoming a part of that human? What if it intentionally became a part of him and watched over the world? That sounded feasible. And the man seemed pretty qualified to be its owner. If that was the case, there wasn't any need to be bothered to dominate and pilot the human.

Whoosh... It started to bring out every bit of its essence and push it all toward Lloyd when his absorption was at its peak. It did so to assimilate into his heart, become a part of him, and hopefully experience freedom in the future. It did so as if it was offering a handshake. In an intentional, friendly, polite, and careful manner. Lloyd's manaheart happily took the handshake.

Whoosh... The Heart of Winter. The divine item that held the strength of one season. Lloyd's manaheart, which was marvelously absorbing everything with the grandmaster's help. At that moment, two strange existences turned into one.

Ding dong.

[The Asrahan Core Technique Skill Option ⑤: Your Supercharge time is up.]

Ziiing... Lloyd's violent mana circle calmed down. The ferocious rotation quietened, and the cold air swirling around him was now gone. Every bit of it. And so was the Heart of Winter, the divine item belonging to the royal house. In addition, a new message appeared in front of Lloyd's eyes.

[You have absorbed the Heart of Winter, a divine item that possesses a consciousness.]

[The strength of the winter season inside the item seeped into your manaheart. This experience is having a strong effect on your manaheart skill.]

[A new skill option has been opened.]

[Manaheart Skill Option ⑤: Time Freeze]

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Chapter 284: How to Freeze Time (2)

“It’s cold. I’ve always hated the cold. But not that there’s any particular reason for it. It’s been like that since I was young. By the way, what was your name? Heart of Winter? I can’t believe you’ve assimilated into me. Why did this have to happen? What for? Aren’t these obvious questions for me to have?”

“It’s hot. I’ve always hated the heat. But not that there’s any grand reason for it. I’ve been like that since I was created. By the way, what was your name? Lloyd Frontera? Now that I’m assimilated, this is going to be harder than I thought. Why do human bodies have to be so hot? Don’t you agree?”

“You make me speechless. I’ve never asked you to assimilate into me. And who gave you permission to whisper inside my unconsciousness? You barged into me, and now you’re yapping? Where are your manners, really? Don’t you see where I’m coming from?”

“You make me speechless, too. Who was it that absorbed everything? I was just a little interested in you. That was all. And yet, you sucked me into your system, and you’re complaining, really? Don’t you see where I’m coming from?”

“You. You’re copying my words. Are you doing it on purpose?”

“You. You’re grumpy. Are you doing it on purpose?”

“Yes, I’m doing this on purpose. Might as well come bearing a gift if you meant to come into me without permission.”

“But I already did.”

“You did?”

“Yeah.”

“Where?”

“Here. Right here. Right now. In front of you.”

“...”

Lloyd opened his eyes. Did he take a nap? Or had he lost track of time for a while? Or...

Did I pass out?

Lloyd blinked. He narrowed his eyes until the focus in his eyes came back, and everything started to be clear. The surroundings around him appeared in his vision. The first thing he saw was the blue sky. It was bright and blinding. Sunlight flooded right into his eyes as if it wanted to grill them.

“Ah, it’s blinding me,” grumbled Lloyd as he frowned and squinted. Then, someone popped into his vision in the corner of the blue sky.

“Master Lloyd, are you awake?” A head. But Lloyd could only see the outlines because of the sunlight. And yet, the man’s head shape alone told of his handsomeness.

“Javier?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd. It is me.” Javier grinned softly. The wind blew to sway his silvery hair, and only then did Lloyd realize he was lying on the ground. And he also noticed the concerned gazes of many people around him. They belonged to the laborers.

“Everyone, you are...” Lloyd hurriedly sat up, which ushered in a terrible pang of dizziness. Javier quickly held out his hand and assisted Lloyd’s back.

“We are outside the cave. You are safe now. So, please rest at ease.”

“...”

Lloyd looked around. It was true. One, two, three, four, and everyone else. Everyone at the site was there. They were gathered under the sun with a

thick blanket as they relaxed and drank hot water. Ppodong and Bangul were in his embrace. That was when he realized.

Everyone made it out safely. I'm safe as well.

Lloyd searched for his memory, and the previous events started to come back to him piece by piece.

I was supervising the upward vertical shaft when I heard a strange explosion and vibration. The Heart of Winter, and the ice storm...

And he started to save all the people, carrying them out one at a time. This process was repeated twenty times. He was exhausted and worn out. At the last moment, he made a decision.

Supercharge.

He took the card out. Everything after that was lost in his head. It was not so surprising. That was what the Supercharge did. You fall into a state of stupor. No situations or changes can be felt.

What happened after that?

Lloyd lifted his head and looked back at Javier, who was supporting his back.

"Hey," called Lloyd.

"Yes, Master Lloyd."

"Did you save me?" Lloyd looked at Javier.

"Yes, probably." Javier smiled mysteriously.

"Then what about Ppodong, Bangul, and the group leader at the site? They were the last to leave."

"Hmm, I am not sure." Javier's smile deepened.

What could that answer mean? Lloyd cocked his head to the side. “You’re not so sure? What do you mean by that?”

“It was me who sensed the accident and came to help you before everyone else, but I am not so sure I can say I saved those you just mentioned.” Javier’s smile turned wry. He knew that his answer was ambiguous. But that was the only answer he could give. Why? Simple.

How should I explain the situation? I do not know.

Javier recalled what had happened. Right after he helped Lloyd’s Supercharge and the Heart of Winter melted into Lloyd’s manaheart, Lloyd lost consciousness. But only his consciousness. He was moving, albeit like a sleepwalker or an inebriated man. Lloyd staggered up to his feet and walked into the cave like a zombie.

Unable to believe his eyes, Javier hurriedly followed Lloyd and stopped the latter, saying that they must go up to safety. Lloyd swiveled at Javier, and he spoke, staring right into his eyes.

“But I am the one in charge.”

Javier was flustered. Lloyd continued mumbling to himself like a drunk.

“Someone’s inside. The group leader is there. He came to work at the construction site because he trusted me. So it’s only right that I save him. Don’t you think?”

“But Master Lloyd,” argued Javier, *“Then I will go in myself-”*

“It has to be me. He’s my responsibility. I am the one in charge. I am the one in charge, Javier.”

“…”

Lloyd couldn’t be talked out of it. He was stubborn. Incorrigible. From then on, Javier silently followed Lloyd into the cave, which was still cold, worrying that the fake Lloyd might fall. On the way, he was granted an audience to fake Lloyd’s soliloquy.

“Everyone is rotten. The site supervisor. The inspecting company. Construction company. Developer. How is that possible? A man fell off. He’d have been saved if the safety net was in place like in the regulation. A man’s spine was smashed, for Pete’s sake. He’s stuck in a wheelchair for life. And no one’s at fault? It’s his fault that he climbed all the way there? To hell with them.”

Javier didn’t say anything. He simply listened.

“Pass the buck, all right. Pass the buck to the innocent. Until the situation gets so convoluted and involves tons of people that no one’s there to hear him out. Drain his mind, and that was when you slipped an envelope into his hand. Oh, and you say what? It’s not my fault, but this is out of courtesy? Wrap it up, this is enough? Wrap it up?! Shoot. Those nut-jobs make me go mad. Even when I’m not the one they’re bothering.”

“...”

“Why are you living like that? That’s not how you should live. But you know what? Life is a stage for the bad guys. That’s not the way it should be. But it is. How much I cursed... the supervisor. He wears an angelic mask. But behind that, he takes bribes. The same goes for the others. I promised myself. I won’t be like them. If I get my license and become in charge, no such thing will happen at my construction site. That’s why I’m doing this.”

“...”

“If I don’t do this, if I avoid this because I’m scared, I’ll be no different than the bastards that I looked down on. And that’s not what I want.”

Master Lloyd... Fake Lloyd. What kind of life did you live? What was your life like in the world I cannot imagine? Javier shook his head. There was no way of knowing or guessing. But one thing was clear. Fake Lloyd’s grumbling and ranting were genuine, and so was his intention to stagger far into the cave.

For some reason, Javier couldn’t get himself to stop Lloyd. Soon, Lloyd arrived at the end of the cave, where he carried the unconscious group

leader even when he couldn’t walk properly. Afterward, he downsized Ppodong and Bangul and placed them in his embrace. He then walked out of the cave, climbed up the high ladder, put the man down under the sun, and passed out. That was what Javier saw happen.

“...”

Javier had a sudden thought. This could have been the most genuine side of Lloyd he ever got a glimpse of.

Moreover... Master Lloyd absorbed the Heart of Winter. All of it. Not a single piece was amiss.

Javier sensed it too as he had helped Lloyd while the Supercharge skill was activated. He was able to feel it from the connected manaheart and mana circle. At the end of the Supercharge, the moment his mana absorption went beyond its limit, the Heart of Winter suddenly grew silent. It had absorbed into Lloyd’s manaheart.

Does fake Lloyd know about it?

Half-worried and half-expectant, Javier looked at Lloyd. He wanted to closely study Lloyd as, after all, it was a divine item that he had absorbed. Would he know what repercussions it’d have? Would it be harmful to him? Or greatly benefit him? Javier decided to keep a close eye on Lloyd. But to Javier’s ignorance, Lloyd was well aware of what happened.

Ha... Crap. This is bad.

He ate the Heart of Winter. The thought of it made him gulp.

All I wanted to achieve by using the Supercharge skill was to absorb some energy and fill up on a bit of mana to escape from the place.

It never occurred to Lloyd that he’d devour the Heart of Winter by the whole. He never knew that was even possible.

How could I ever think that was possible? It’s the Heart of Winter. One of the divine items in the House of Magentano. It was an impressive artifact.

But what about his Supercharge? Sure, what I have is a great skill too. After all, I defeated the undead Mastodons and Hell's Knight with it. But it has its clear limits.

Though it was very good at absorbing mana, it had its limits. It couldn't absorb beyond a certain capacity. A case in point was when he used the skill against the Bone Dragon.

At that time, the total volume Draggy carried was just another level... Supercharge? It was like trying to drain a lake with a bucket.

And so, he barely did any damage to Draggy. He thought it'd be the same case this time. He thought it wouldn't be enough to absorb the Heart of Winter since it was a divine item belonging to the royal house. All he expected was to absorb a tiny portion of the cold air being emitted out. That was enough for him. Fill up the empty manaheart, recharge, and save Ppodong, Bangul, and the group leader. That was all he wanted.

But this? Woah. Could it be that the Heart of Winter doesn't have as large of a reserve as I thought?

He couldn't help but think so. It was that outrageous of a situation. Sure, Lloyd was glad. But given the item's unimaginable value, Lloyd was forced to worry about the repercussions.

Tsk. Should I just make excuses? The Heart of Winter ran amok, and it broke. Yeah. That should be more believable to the others. Who would believe me if I told them I absorbed it?

Lloyd then stole a glance at Javier on the side. Could it be that he felt the gaze? Javier turned and faced Lloyd. And to Lloyd's surprise, he whispered, "Master Lloyd, just tell them that it broke."

"Wait... Did you know about the absorption?" Lloyd's voice broke.

"Yes. Thanks to the Asrahan Core Technique, I have been able to feel it. And that is why..." Javier paused and stared right into Lloyd's eyes. Lloyd

held his gaze without saying anything. “Since the others do not know that there is such a skill, no one will know as long as we keep our mouths shut.”

Lloyd’s mouth opened slightly in surprise. “But a divine item of the imperial is the one that would be broken. I’m surprised that you would suggest this.”

“Nothing to be surprised, Master Lloyd. My loyalty is to the lord, not the queen.”

“You mean you want to prevent putting the family in a hard place because I absorbed the Heart of Winter, right?”

“I heard nothing. I do not have a clue what you are saying, and I am ignorant of the whole thing.” With that, Javier clamped his mouth shut. Lloyd licked his lips as he stared at Javier.

You know he can be quite playful and cheeky. Anyway, I should just tell the queen that it broke after it went savage. Ugh, but it won’t save me from the chaos that will ensue.

He might have to pay for the damage. If not, at least be liable for the way the construction site was managed. But Lloyd didn’t worry about it too much. The queen was on his side, and everyone was rescued and alive.

Oh, whatever. I saved people. That’s enough. I should be content with that.

That thinking relieved some burden off his heart. And a few seconds later, he received good news. The stabbed royal magician Lloyd had saved before anyone else lived after receiving emergency treatment.

It must be because of the wound that froze.

That must be what stopped the bleeding and saved him. Lloyd was glad. And soon, every part of his body relaxed at ease. That was when something in the corner of his vision caught his attention. It was the skill message notification that had been floating.

What’s this?

His gaze moved.

[A new manaheart skill option is available.]

[Manaheart Skill Option ⑤: Time Freeze]

Time freeze?

Lloyd was confused. The new option was freezing time?

Am I getting this because I absorbed the Heart of Winter?

It appeared so. He opened the description as a sense of excitement crept into him.

Ding dong.

[Skill Option ⑤: Time Freeze - Allows you to freeze the world's passage of time by borrowing the power of the Heart of Winter in your manaheart. The user can designate an area of exception, a no-freeze zone, and the area's range is determined by the user's total volume of mana. Inside the no-freeze zones, time will progress normally.]

[More Information (1): The range of no-freeze zones cannot be changed until the effect is deactivated. You can stop time for up to a period of one year.]

[More Information (2): The effect is deactivated in the event the user goes out of the no-freeze zone.]

[More Information (3): All living creatures (including the user) can freely go around within the no-freeze zone. However, due to the frigid air of the Heart of Winter, they will not age.]

[More Information (4): It costs 3,000 RP every time to activate the option.]

"Damn. This is amazing." Lloyd murmured to himself after reading the detailed information.

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Chapter 285: How to Freeze Time (3)

“Damn... This is amazing.”

Lloyd murmured involuntarily. It just slipped out. How can it not? Time was fair to everyone. It dutifully flowed onward. But now, Lloyd came to somewhat possess control over it. If the description in front of his eyes was true, he could now take part in the flow of time.

So, I’m using the power of the Heart of Winter in my manaheart. I can freeze time in this world.

This was too much, Lloyd thought to himself. This skill was transcendental. Godly.

But I shouldn’t get too pumped up.

Lloyd got a grip on himself and didn’t allow himself to cheer or get carried away in joy. Instead, he meticulously studied the description, picking at its words, thinking, and looking at it with suspicion.

It’s too good of an optional skill. It’s so amazing it leaves me speechless.

Like everything, if a deal or award sounded too good to be true, it was a trap. There was no such thing as a free lunch in this world. There was no such thing as a giving tree. Lloyd believed that the first thing he should do when someone shoves a much too sweet deal up to his face was to be a skeptic. And that was how he managed to survive all these years. The same thing was happening now.

There wasn’t a time the system message deceived me. But this one’s too good to be true. So, I should be careful, investigate, and confirm it myself.

He shouldn’t be overjoyed. First, he needed to organize his thoughts.

To sum up everything, I can freeze time in this world, but I can designate certain areas to be excluded. If so, time will flow in those areas normally,

but no one will age.

The more he chewed it over, the better the option was. But, of course, it came with some restrictions.

Once the skill is activated, time can freeze only up to a year. And it's impossible to change the no-freeze zone until I deactivate the skill. Also, it gets automatically deactivated when I leave the no-freeze area. Plus, using the skill comes with a price. One usage costs me a whopping 3,000 RP.

Lloyd checked how much RP he had.

Hmm... 2,665. It's not quite enough.

He wanted to use the skill and confirm its capabilities right away. But he couldn't. He didn't have enough RP.

Looks like it's time for some RP hunt.

Better yet, Lloyd wondered if there was any opportunity he could explosively up his likeability. He figured he ought to collect more than 3,000 RP, even if it took some toil on his part.

Since it's the most perfect and best thing that ever happened to me.

The mere thought of it made his heart thump in excitement. He couldn't help it even when he tried to calm down. But how could he not? He could come up with millions of ways to use the skill to his advantage.

I can use it for the most urgent matter right now- finding the materials for the Aotearoa and conducting the construction. I didn't have much time left, and it was starting to irk me.

Just then, the Ending Spoiler came to his mind. And the restoration of destiny. Lloyd now had two years and a half until that effing event started to roll. But he had too many tasks to accomplish before then. That was the problem. That was what was gnawing at him.

I've got to collect all the key materials for the jewel's construction in two and a half years. Only the heavens know how long that will take. But will it be over after I find them? No. I've got to build the jewel. What about after? I've got to ask and find a way to stop the restoration of destiny.

He also knew that there was no chance his job would end after getting an answer.

Once I have the solution, I'll get busy again trying to put it all into action.

He had no way of knowing what the solution would look like. But he figured it wouldn't be simple. It was also a mystery how much time it'd take. And yet, despite everything, he only had two and a half years, and the thought had been making him toss and turn in the middle of the night.

But now. I have this spectacular option. From finding the materials to building the jewel... Each time I build something, I should simply freeze time after I designate the work site as a no-freeze area. That way, I'll be able to work while the world's time has been stopped. A few months. A year. It doesn't matter how long the construction will take. Time will be frozen anyway.

It appeared that he'd be able to save an obscene amount of time.

And if all my efforts, all this drudgery ends up futile, and if I can't stop destiny, then I'll just freeze time after designating Frontera County as a no-freeze area. It sounds kind of drastic, but well. I'll be earning one year's worth of time. Meanwhile, I'll have to rack my brain and figure something out. All the while, the world's clock is put on pause.

Yes, it was a drastic method. But it was a good band-aid solution for if he became stuck.

Anyway, having such an option alone is extremely useful.

Lloyd resolved to himself: He would work harder to collect RP. Just then, an unexpected voice pierced his ears.

“Are you fine?”

“Hmm...?” Lloyd was jostled out of his trance, and when he looked up, he saw an outline of a figure looking down at him with the sun behind her back. Wavy short hair. A wry smile on her face.

“Your Majesty.” When Lloyd saw her take three steps further and smile mysteriously, he immediately got down to his knee and said, “Hail to Her Majesty. I, Lloyd Frontera, the eldest son of the Frontera County, am honored to be in the audience of the rightful owner of this-”

“There is no need for formalities in this circumstance. I asked how you are,” she said gravely.

“Your Majesty?” asked Lloyd.

“I am asking if you are hurt.”

“As you can see, Your Majesty, I am completely fine.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd nodded promptly and felt flustered.

Crap. This is bad. I haven’t thought up an excuse yet.

One thing had led to another, and Lloyd inadvertently absorbed the Heart of Winter, which he had borrowed from the queen. It wasn’t any royal treasure. It was a divine item of the imperial family. He still hadn’t thought of a believable excuse as he was busy reading through his new optional skill and thinking of ways to utilize it. He had become too excited, despite his efforts not to, and thus, failed to prepare any excuses yet. He had never expected to face the queen so quickly.

Tsk. What should I tell her?

Lloyd racked his brain. The events that occurred at this scene. The myriad of different circumstances he saw during the accident. His actions and their results. The expected response from the queen and the public. Lloyd

recalled, compounded, and predicted every one of these things, running a plethora of scenarios and adjusting his reactions to them. Not too long after, he was ready to make a case for himself in a sly voice and was about to speak when the queen questioned him first.

“Looking at the situation, I assume that the Heart of Winter has been lost. Am I right?”

“Oh, Your Majesty. If I could explain-”

“There’s no need,” the queen interrupted in a gentle voice. “I came here after realizing what had happened.”

“...”

Lloyd stared at the queen. For some reason, he couldn’t get a clear read of her expression or eyes. There was something strange about her tone and expression. Could it be that she was angry?

I’d be angry if someone broke a precious item I’d lent them.

Lloyd then thought that apologizing and begging for her forgiveness seemed to be a better choice to improve his relationship with her. Just then, the queen spoke something that took Lloyd by surprise.

“I have heard,” she said, “From the one of the guard knights you saved. When he opened the door to the refrigeration room, something already happened, and two royal magicians were covered in blood. He said it looked like one stabbed the other.”

Lloyd didn’t say anything.

“I presume that whatever happened between the two magicians accounts for this incident. Although there will be a series of additional investigations, judging from the witnesses of the guard, I can assume that you are not directly liable for it.”

Lloyd’s eyes softened.

“I also heard that,” she went on. “You risked your life saving the magicians and guards. And how you willingly jumped to save the laborers trapped inside the cave. Thus, how could I lash out at you for this?”

“Um, Your Majesty, please forgive me, but...”

“Tell me.”

“Why is it that you favor me to this extent?” There was genuine curiosity in Lloyd’s eyes.

“Are you curious?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” Lloyd spoke frankly. He was surprised by her response and attitude. Her willingness to exonerate him from this whole mess. The queen chuckled once again.

“I am not favoring you or confirming what you have done is right. I am simply informing you.”

“What is it for, Your Majesty?”

“Consider this an example of the statement you will make when you are under the inquiry of the House of Peers.” Her smile softened. “Since an accident broke out nonetheless on your construction site and resulted in the loss of the royal house’s divine item, this is extremely grave and significant, whatever my personal feelings lay,” said Queen Magentano.

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“That is why I am doing this. The House of Peers will not let this slide as it had given its consensus to the usage of the Heart of Winter. It is likely that they will soon submit a bill of indictment and petition to the courtroom.”

“Will they, Your Majesty?”

“Yes,” the queen said as she nodded. “Since you are my meritorious retainer and have legal immunity that limits any judgment on you to me, they will file a request to have you stand in front of court.”

“Oh.”

Lloyd saw this coming. He nodded. The queen continued to speak.

“Moreover, I will have to grant the request from the House of Peers. There is no reason for me not to. After all, I should be the one flying into a rage and sending you into the courtroom.”

“But why is it that Your Majesty is not-”

“Are you asking why I am siding with you?”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” affirmed Lloyd.

“I like you.”

“Your Majesty?” Lloyd raised his head, taken aback by her response. She was smiling. He even caught some playfulness in her eyes.

“To me, I find you are much more useful than a divine item I can only use twice or thrice in a span of a few centuries. Whereas you will be of use to me for several decades. Don’t you agree?”

“Um, that is a very direct way to say you’re going to make me work...”

“This is my investment in you as a talent. Don’t you think so?”

“Not at all, Your Majesty,” denied Lloyd.

“Tsk. You do not have to refuse me so cold-heartedly.”

“Consider it a tantrum borne out of guilt for causing trouble, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd cast his head down, genuinely feeling apologetic and grateful at the same time.

She is openly telling me that she’ll cover for me in the future. We’re talking about the loss of a divine item here. Yet, she’s going to overlook it.

Surely, the queen was no ordinary monarch. She was a big-hearted queen. And her outspoken intent to put him to useful work? Lloyd partly understood her greed.

Well. She has been generous to me. She didn't lash out when I sucked her mana with my Supercharge during the assassination attempt against her. Moreover, she's been showering my fiefdom with large amounts of supply aid since the Monster Domino incident. There are also several other instances when I received special treatment from her.

Come to think of it, the queen was his biggest source of help in overcoming the obstacles he had faced until now. But, of course, it didn't mean that he intended to become her servant.

It's not like I've done nothing for her.

He had given and done as much for her as he had received from her. That alone was enough. So, Lloyd decided to happily accept her assistance. He would just return the favor at another time.

"Words fall short of my gratitude to you, Your Majesty," Lloyd expressed sincerely. And he was also grateful that everyone was safe. Now, it was time to clean up the mess.

♣

A few days passed. The construction site was cleaned up in no time. To Lloyd's relief, the cave didn't suffer much damage. The frozen ground wasn't affected, either. It looked like the remaining portion of the construction could resume normal operation without delay. However, something else stopped the construction from resuming. The House of Peers filed a petition against Lloyd, submitting a bill of indictment to hold him responsible for losing the Heart of Winter.

The queen was right.

Things took place as she had expected. She accepted the bill from the House of Peers and announced the date for the trial. Meanwhile, Lloyd

enjoyed his rare break as days passed. At last, the day of the trial came.

“Are you ready, Master Lloyd? We should leave now if you do not want to be late.”

“Yes, hold on.” Lloyd stood in front of the mirror. It was the first day of the trial. When Javier insisted they must leave now, he replied, “Hold on a second. Let me just finish my warm-up exercise.”

“What warm-up exercise?” asked Javier.

“Stretching my tongue.” Lloyd knew. In a fierce court battle, his tongue would be his weapon. Smiling mischievously at the mirror, Lloyd licked his lips.

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Chapter 286: The Defendant's Method of Blackmail (1)

Rattle. Rattle. The carriage shook, but not like the carts drawn around in the markets. Regardless, it still had a rattle as it wasn't a car with a modern suspension device. He could feel even the smallest bump from his buttocks.

Well, it's better than being crammed into a bus during rush hour and getting attacked by the sweaty underarms of the person behind me.

Lloyd smiled faintly as he recalled one of his memories from South Korea for a moment. This was much better than those days. He had a large and soft luxury leather seat all to himself right now. He could comfortably cross his legs and chat with Javier who was sitting across from him.

"Don't you think so, Javier?"

Lloyd's words brought Javier to lift his head. Tearing his gaze away from the papers, Javier stared hard at Lloyd. "What do you mean what I think? By the way, are you not worried?"

"Worried?" Lloyd shot him a quizzical look.

"About today's trial." The bottom of the papers was tapped into an organized bundle. Javier held it out to Lloyd. "You will arrive at the court any minute now, and the trial will commence right after. Will you be all right not reading this in advance?"

"Yes," said Lloyd with confidence. "I am fine."

"Even when this paper details the points that will be mentioned in the courtroom?"

"Uh-huh," affirmed Lloyd again as he nodded. He was sure. He didn't have to read it. "I already have a good idea of what's inside without reading it."

"Hmm." Javier tapped his fingers. "Are you sure?"

“Well, try testing me if you want,” Lloyd said as he sat up straight.

Javier’s eyes narrowed. “Fine. What is the biggest charge the House of Peers has against you?”

“The loss of the Heart of Winter, which is a divine item of the imperial family. They’re demanding that I take responsibility for it since I was in charge of the site where the accident took place.”

“You got that right. One point for you.”

“What was that?” snapped Lloyd. “Are you counting points now?”

“I will continue.”

“Hold on,” stopped Lloyd, holding up his hand.

“Yes?”

“What’s the best possible score?” asked Lloyd.

“100.”

“But that question was worth only one point.”

“It was the easiest and most basic question I have. To be frank, if you don’t even know what the court is charging you with, you might as well jump out of the carriage right this minute.”

“But this carriage is passing a suspension bridge,” Lloyd pointed out in confusion.

“Yes,” sighed Javier with glee, “What a splendid morning to check out the water temperature.” Ignoring the dazed look on Lloyd’s face, Javier continued his test. “Next question. What punishment did the House of Peers demand for you while making their accusation?”

“Strip me of my title as a meritorious retainer.”

“You got that right. Ten points.”

“Oooh!”

“Do not get ahead of yourself. What do they want by stripping you of your status?”

“Obviously,” Lloyd huffed, “They want to take away the privileges I have and taint my reputation. If I’m stripped of my title as a meritorious retainer right after I earn it, it’d leave a huge damage to my reputation. I might as well not have received it in the first place instead. History will remember my name with dishonor.”

“Correct. 30 points. Plus, once your title is gone, they will truly start attacking you.”

“I think so, too. Since I’ll lose the privilege of no-arrest and legal immunity.”

“That is right,” agreed Javier, “Once they arrest you, you will be put in front of the court presided by the House of Peers.”

“Tsk. I guess this country doesn’t have the principle of ne bis in idem.” Lloyd looked out the window.

“What was that?”

Lloyd turned and said, “Nothing. Anyway, it’d be like taking away my shield before stabbing my heart.”

Lloyd could see it already. Despite that, he was not scared in the slightest. But he was worried that the situation could get bothersome for him. Meanwhile, Javier continued with his questions.

“If so, do you have a guess on why they’re so insistent on attacking you?”

“Yeah.” Lloyd nodded. It was so obvious that he didn’t have to read the document to know the answer. “Because I am dashingly handsome.”

“Wrong,” Javier made a repulsive face. “Minus 100 points.”

“...”

“Please answer seriously. We are arriving at the courtroom soon,” pleaded Javier in a serious voice.

“Tsk. Since I’m just a nobody from the countryside. A parvenu in the eyes of the capital nobles. And I’ve got a history of revealing the corruption in the royal academy, which propelled the queen to wield her wrathful power against quite a number of noble children and professors. I imagine a considerable number of families were waiting for a chance to pounce on me.”

“I am relieved that you are aware of it. Then, next question.”

“Hold on. My answer is correct. How many points do I get?”

“None.”

“Why not?” Lloyd’s voice broke.

“Since you gave a completely ludicrous answer before you gave the right one.”

“Hey, if you look closely from various angles, I can pass as handsome-”

“Next question,” Javier immediately put in. “What should you do to effectively refute the accusations the House of Peers will make against you at court?”

“How about kneeling down and begging them to let it go this once?”

“...”

“I’m serious. I’m not lying.”

“Master Lloyd.” Javier stared hard at Lloyd.

“Yeah. What?”

“Are you confident that you can win at court?”

“Of course I do. It’ll be a clean finish. I will trounce them.”

Lloyd had no doubt about it. But before he could spell his plan out to Javier, the carriage came to a stop.

“Looks like we’re here. Let’s go.”

Lloyd immediately opened the carriage door before Javier could scold him, and the royal courtroom appeared in his view. That was the place for today’s trial. Lloyd went in. The trial was ready to start soon. After touching up his clothes, Lloyd received a walk-through of today’s trial from the courtroom administrator. The etiquette and order of speakers in court. And later, the trial commenced.

Woah. What an impressive structure this building has.

Lloyd’s gaze traveled the width of the courtroom as he stood at the defendant’s seat. It was dominating. The place was designed like a miniature baseball stadium, with the defendant’s seat as the batter’s box. That was where Lloyd would sit. To his right was the place of the first baseman. That was the seating for the head of the House of Peers, who will question Lloyd today. On his left, the third baseman, was the place for the legislative officials offering the queen advice regarding the sentence. And the center, the place for the pitcher, was reserved for the queen.

And the rest of the audience will watch the trial from afar, from the spot of the outfielders. Tsk. What’s worse is how the seats are dramatically tiered. Mine is the lowest one.

The defendant's seat was tiered in the lowest. About 10 feet deep. The room was structured with a steep, much like a college lecture hall, so everyone, minus the defendant, looked down at the defendant.

Aha. It's designed to psychologically pressure the defendant. Here, all their crimes and wrongdoings will be spelled out. Their punishments will be discussed while everyone stares down at the defendant. By doing that, the defendant will naturally feel small. With this kind of terrible pressure, anyone's shoulders will droop by reflex.

Lloyd fought hard not to smile. Who cared if the seats were designed this way?

Victory will be mine anyway.

Lloyd decided to get this trial over with, resume his construction project, and harvest the pieces of tauranga as soon as possible. Meanwhile, the queen's declaration of open session was made.

"I hereby declare."

Queen Magentano rose from her seat, and everyone followed suit. Grave silence ruled over the courtroom before being broken by the queen's declaration.

"I openly declare that today's trial, which takes place on the ninth of this month, will discuss his responsibility for the leakage of frigid air of the Heart of Winter at the palatial repair construction site, the loss of the Heart of Winter, and various other matters. But before anything else, I want to express some words of comfort to the royal magicians, guard knights, and laborers who suffered from the accident."

Her gaze raked through the courtroom. And then it stopped on Lloyd.

"First, the defendant."

"Yes, Your Majesty." Lloyd immediately lowered his head.

She asked, "I shall check your identity first. Are you the successor and eldest son of the Frontera family, Lloyd Frontera?"

"Yes, I am, Your Majesty."

“Good. Let it be known that you have the right to deny making statements based on your subjective judgment and to refuse to answer questions throughout the trial. However, there will be no one but you who will be held responsible for how you exercise your rights. Does the defendant understand the meaning of my words?”

“I do, Your Majesty.” Lloyd lowered his head.

“Good. Then. Duke Toscano.” Her gaze moved to Duke Toscano. A short, chubby man who looked like a bulldog gave his respects to the queen. Duke Toscano was the head of the House of Peers.

He’s the one who accused me. Though it wasn’t his sole decision.

Lloyd smiled. The man was a heavyweight who represented the central nobles of the kingdom. He was also related to the imperial family by blood. The queen continued giving her declaration and notice speech.

“Duke Toscano, you shall conduct yourself in the courtroom solely guided by the aim to realize the grave law and justice of the kingdom. Moreover, you shall not involve your personal feelings in the trial, and in the process of proving the charges outlined in the bill of indictment, you are forbidden to ask leading questions that will prompt the defendant to give the answers of your desire and must respect and pursue the process of fair trial. Do you understand the meaning of my words?”

“I do, Your Majesty.”

Duke Toscano bowed politely. The queen’s face froze a little, and a faint glint of concern appeared in her eyes.

Will he be able to exonerate himself from today’s trial?

The more she thought about it, the more worried she became. A sense of doubt filled her heart, mainly because of Duke Toscano. This was the man who submitted the bill of indictment against Lloyd as the head of the House of Peers. And he was set to interrogate Lloyd today.

Duke Toscano is a stubborn fundamentalist.

Much like his bulldog-like appearance, he was an extremely stubborn man. A stickler for rules. He rarely deviated from the routines he had set for himself. And yet, that man was here to charge Lloyd for his crimes. That was the part the queen was worried about the most.

He will not easily let go of Frontera. He will be like a hellbent bulldog who will let go of his bite only if Lloyd's crimes are paid for.

Moreover, he wasn't the only problem. There was something else, too.

The entire House of Peers supports him.

The mere thought of that made her sigh. The thing was, even if she was presiding over the trial today and giving the final verdict, she wasn't in the position to dismiss every charge against Lloyd and side with him.

That is how serious the matter is. One of the divine items of the royal house was lost.

The Heart of Winter was, no doubt, a crucial object. It was the artifact given by Ice Dragon Tyrannus to the founding king, Mikael Magentano. A strategic weapon that held the power of a winter. That was what was lost. Its loss was national, so priceless that it couldn't be translated into value. As such, even if she was the queen and Lloyd was the meritorious retainer, she couldn't cover for him without a clear ground. What was more, the process of how the Heart of Winter came to be used rose as another contending issue.

It can be used only if the kingdom is on the brink of collapse or if the queen requests to use it. It can only be used with unanimous agreement from the nobles in the House of Peers.

As the protocol dictated, Queen Magentano filed a request to use the Heart of Winter. At first, the nobles expressed dismay. The palatial repair didn't constitute a national emergency. That was the initial response of the House of Peers, extremely obvious and reasonable. And so, she met up with each

noble to persuade them, sometimes sweet-talking or bribing them, until she reached a consensus. But now, despite the political risk she allowed herself, the item was gone. So, technically speaking, she was slightly responsible for the loss.

Therefore, I cannot stand by Lloyd's side so openly. That will make the House of Peers turn its back on me.

A grimace appeared on her face, the lines of her forehead wrinkling. Even though she was a queen with powerful political power, she couldn't entirely ignore the House of Peers. The national affair went smoothly only if the monarch's leadership harmonized with the cooperation of the House of Peers. That was how her legitimacy could be maintained and also why she was worried.

She was worried that Duke Toscano was dead serious about charging Lloyd for his sins. If so, how should she protect Lloyd without showing her favor? While she was wrapped up in her concern, Duke Toscano rose from his seat to speak.

"My deepest respects to the sacred courtroom and to Her Majesty the Great. I shall start my statement. First, defendant Lloyd Frontera holds the impressive accomplishment of preventing an assassination attempt against the queen, and he is truly a role model for taking in tens and thousands of refugees after protecting his fiefdom from the disaster."

What?!

Queen Magentano couldn't believe her ears. Why was he complimenting Lloyd now? The series of compliments deepened her frown as she tried to figure out what the man was up to. Meanwhile, he continued.

"It does not end there. Lloyd Frontera inspired others by confronting the catastrophe that fell on Namaran without hesitation. He also came before anyone else to help Her Majesty when the Bone Dragon attacked. For his accomplishments, he was appointed as a meritorious retainer of the royal house. But that is not all. Even with the unfortunate accident of the Heart of Winter..."

“...”

Queen Magentano cocked her head to the side. Something was definitely odd here. Even the jury exchanged looks as they whispered among themselves. Unperturbed, Duke Toscano went on to praise Lloyd.

“Even when the divine item went on a rampage... He didn’t cower despite the terrifying situation... Rolled up his sleeves to save the laborers, the precious people of the royal house... He did his best...”

“...”

Could it be that he had lost it? Queen Magentano started to become seriously concerned about him. This whole event was unfolding very differently from what she had in mind.

I doubt he’s gone mad.

Originally, the duke was supposed to accuse, rebuke, and question Lloyd Frontera. That was why he had submitted the bill of indictment and came to this place. So, it was a wonder as he was busy overlooking and complimenting Lloyd from the start.

I cannot wrap my head around this at all.

Could it be that she was dreaming? She seriously considered the thought. That was how dumbfounding and dismaying this situation was for her.

But she wasn’t alone. The jury was as befuddled as her. They all exchanged glances, saying among themselves that the duke was strange today and acting like Lloyd’s lawyer. They whispered and murmured among themselves in confusion.

While the duke went on, a satisfied smile hung on Lloyd’s mouth. And he thought: It was the same for anywhere in the world. Blood, education, and regional connections. Plus, blackmailing and bribing. With all those combined, anything was possible in this world.

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Chapter 287: The Defendant’s Method of Blackmail (2)

Rattle. Rattle. The carriage shook, but not like the carts drawn around in the markets. Regardless, it still had a rattle as it wasn’t a car with a modern suspension device. However, Lloyd didn’t pay attention to it. His trial had ended successfully. The ruling he received was exactly what he expected.

My blackmailing worked like a charm because they had too much to lose. The head and the other members of the House of Peers.

Lloyd smiled faintly. The event back at the court flashed across his mind. He felt good. Refreshed. Duke Toscano acted exactly the way Lloyd wanted to and accepted all of his demands despite the man’s intractable character. Thanks to that, Lloyd was now on cloud nine while heading back to his chamber, enjoying the expensive, spacious, and velvety leather seat.

“Don’t you think so, Javier?”

When he heard his name, Javier, who was looking out the window, turned and stared at Lloyd. “What about? By the way, what did you do?”

“What? What did I do?” Lloyd asked defensively.

“At today’s trial,” Javier went on, “The more I think about it, it is strange. Duke Toscano had rolled up his sleeves to condemn and charge you for what happened at the construction site.”

“Yeah, he did.”

“So it is beyond my comprehension why he suddenly changed his attitude and advocated for you.”

“Is that why you’re doubting me? Do you think I used some sort of trickery?”

“Yes, Young Master.”

“Come on, trickery? How can you look so relaxed after saying those brazen words,” wailed Lloyd

“Mind you,” Javier raised his voice a little. “You were the one who used such a description.”

Lloyd pretended he didn’t hear him. “Anyway, you’re suggesting that I’ve done something shady under the table that changed the nobles’ attitude. Right?”

“Yes, you are right. Did you really do something shady?”

“Uh-huh.” Lloyd flashed a grin at him. No need to deny it. “I blackmailed him.”

“Blackmailed?” Javier lifted his brow.

“Yeah, I did it right after the day after the House of Peers submitted the bill of indictment.”

“How could you have possibly blackmailed him? You never stepped out of your room.”

“I sent a letter, via Ggoming, to Marquess Bergamo.”

“A letter?”

“Yes.”

Lloyd nodded. Just then, the events of the previous days came to his mind, from the day the Heart of Winter went berserk to the day of cleaning up the mess. He didn’t laze around as the others had thought he did. He was pretending to relax around in bed but did all the work that needed to be done.

I analyzed the accident site. Thankfully, I unconsciously had my design skills on when I arrived at the accident site, allowing me to scan the whole site.

The blown-up refrigerant room. The shattered control chest and passed-out royal magicians and knights. The formation of cracks and scatters, as well as the position and location of the victims. All of the information he had about these events was scanned and saved as a piece of data. This enabled Lloyd to summon the image of the accident in his head in the comfort of his bed and conduct a thorough, slow, and meticulous analysis of the whole situation.

“I found the smoking gun. The fifth son of Marquess Bergamo. He was the only one who died in the accident. I found conclusive evidence that it was his doing.”

“What was it...?” A line of frown appeared in between Javier’s brows.

Lloyd shrugged. “I found the skin of someone’s palm ripped on the cover of the destroyed control chest.”

“The skin of someone’s palm, Young Master?” asked Javier.

“Yeah.”

Lloyd was telling the truth. Indeed, the skin of someone’s entire palm was glued to the chest facade. It was undeniable evidence that pointed to the fifth son of Marquess Bergamo.

“Hey,” went on Lloyd, “Do you know what happens if you stick your tongue against a cold piece of metal in the freezing winter?”

“I know. It sticks to the metal.”

“Right? And what happens if you try to pull it off by force?”

“A terrible idea. Your frozen skin would rip off.”

“That’s exactly right. That’s what seemed to have happened with the piece of skin on the chest.”

“Do you mean... that it belonged to the fifth son of Marquess Bergamo?”

“Yes,” said Lloyd confidently, nodding for emphasis. “I saw it when I arrived at the scene. That royal magician’s hand was bleeding. The blood had frozen because of the cold, but it definitely looked like it had been ripped off.”

This, however, was a lie. Lloyd hadn’t observed anything like that when he got to the scene because he was too out of his mind to catch that sort of small detail. But he nonetheless knew and was 100% sure about it. After all, he was able to look back at the scene in his head for observation and analysis purposes.

“So, what else could it mean other than the magician had put his hand on the control chest, prompted the Heart of Winter to go on a rampage, and then wreak havoc on the place by emitting cold air? That was when his hand got stuck. You know what happened afterward. Boom. The control chest exploded.”

“So,” contributed Javier, “The explosion must have shoved him and forcefully tore his hand away. Hence, the skin of his palm was left stuck on the control chest.”

“Correct.” Lloyd grinned. Javier’s deduction was right. “This evidence was too conclusive. I had circumstantial evidence that he was our guy, not to mention I had the testimonies of the royal knights that he stabbed his colleague, but I didn’t have any direct witnesses.”

“Certainly,” affirmed Javier gravely, “For all we know, the stabbed magician might have framed himself as a victim when he was the one who was at fault.”

“That’s exactly right. It’s not entirely impossible since they’re magicians, although the chances are small. The man could’ve stabbed his own back using magic and blamed it on his colleague.”

“But the ripped piece of skin ruled out the possibility of that.”

“Yeah. I’m telling you. It’s a smoking gun.”

Javier furrowed his brows. “Well then, um, I see. You then sent a threatening letter to Marquess Bergamo that the dirty secret of his son would be put out in the open unless the House of Peers changed its stance. Is my guess correct?”

“Yeah, I say, you’re quite good.” Lloyd flashed a mischievous smile. Javier was right. “What do you think would happen if I disclosed everything, including the smoking gun? The investigative body in the palace will have to conduct another investigation, only this time more focused on the new evidence. The result? The Bergamo family will take every fault. Sure, I won’t be entirely exonerated. I was in charge of the site when the accident happened. But I’ll receive lighter punishment compared to the Bergamo family.”

“I certainly think so. More so now when you have become a hero to the people.”

Javier smiled, remembering that Lloyd had become the hero of the capital in the past few days. Everyone adored him for a simple reason. The eldest son of the count and meritorious retainer of the Magentano imperial family had rolled up his sleeves to save the plebian laborers under him. This heartwarming news spread like wildfire across the capital through the mouths of the laborers and their families as well as other relatives.

“The public opinion has tipped over to your favor, and once it was proven that you are not the direct cause of the accident, your punishment would have been as light as a feather.”

“Yeah,” agreed Lloyd heartily, “Plus, I had the status and privileges of a meritorious retainer of the imperial family. I’d have gotten a small scolding from Her Majesty. A verbal warning. But the marquess? He would’ve caused an uproar.”

“It would have really been so if you revealed the evidence in court.” That was when Javier understood the whole situation. And he thought to himself further that the fake Lloyd was a sly man. A cunning, manipulative, and small-hearted man. But those qualities were what made him great.

Right. If this piece of evidence was revealed, hmm, the Bergamo family wouldn't have been able to avoid a grave punishment as they directly created the cause for the loss of the royal house's divine item. Their sin would be graver than treason. In the worst case, their family could have fallen.

That would not be the only consequence. The sword of reckoning could reach all the noble houses related to the marquess by blood. It was possible that their crime would be considered worse than treason.

The thing is, Marquess Bergamo and Duke Toscano are in-laws. Duke Toscano is the former's father-in-law.

In other words, Duke Toscano was the maternal grandfather of the culprit. The central nobles who had influence over the House of Peers were tightly connected to each other by blood, location, and education. And so, any punishment that was similar to exterminating the family would have affected every noble related to the marquess in varying degrees.

What a dirty method.

Javier couldn't help but smile wryly.

"That is why the head of the House of Peers changed his stance. He looked like he was ready to risk his life for you."

"Well, you could say that."

The same smile hung on Lloyd's face now. His meticulously designed blackmail worked, which was about how they'd be guillotined if he received a guilty sentence. Since the powerful nobles had a lot to lose and were trapped by their social network of connections from education, blood, and region, Lloyd simply had to softly suggest that they would be rewarded in the future so long they did what he demanded. Eventually, thanks to his blackmail and bribery, the trial went how Lloyd wanted it to.

As for the queen, she just had to go along the flow as she was already advocating for Lloyd. So, at the very moment the Duke Toscano

unexpectedly rooted for Lloyd, she simply echoed his words in joy.

When Duke Toscano said that Lloyd was a true patriot, Queen Magentano replied that he was right. When he argued that punishing Lloyd would be more damaging than more beneficial, she repeated that he was right.

As for Lloyd himself, he had to only throw some groveling remarks here and there, things like “I will follow the great will of Your Majesty.” And the final verdict: “The loss of the Heart of Winter is painful, but Lloyd holds no substantial responsibility over this incident as the item went into a frenzy due to magical instability, something beyond human control. As such, placing all the responsibility on Lloyd, the imperial family’s meritorious retainer, for this is extremely harsh. Only a small fine will be levied on him for neglecting his work site.” That was the verdict.

“Thanks to that, a slap on the wrist is all I’ve got. And everything went well. Now, time to get to work!”

Indeed. It didn’t mean that Lloyd could rest now just because the trial ended. He still had jobs to do at the site, and it was something that he berated.

I seriously want to grab the author of The Knight of Blood and Iron *by the neck and give him a terrible shake for planning out this merciless world.*

Lloyd berated his fate of having to live in this kind of world setting instead of an easy, happy-go-lucky one. Fighting back the urge to rant about his life, he continued his work to extract the tauranga in the structure. Since the construction was already in its final stage of nearing the isolated piers of the foundation, it was not done before long. After five days, Lloyd reached his desired point of progression.

Found it!

At last, the isolated piers of the foundation revealed itself. A rectangular piece of tauranga that was about sixteen feet in width and nineteen feet in width was stuck in the middle. By this time, Lloyd started to carefully start his work. Ppodong joined the effort, and so did Javier. The stone was

harvested and replaced with another piece of material, and cement was applied for adhesion. This process was repeated twelve times. At last, the moment the twelfth piece of tauranga was harvested safely...

Ding dong.

[You have attained twelve pieces of the tauranga stone, a key material for the Jewel of Truth.]

[You have succeeded in excavating the key material of Aotearoa that was destroyed during the mythical age.]

[This is truly an impressive excavation that will be remembered in history.]

[When the Jewel of Truth is restored, your name will be remembered in history as the excavator who found this key material.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 2,000 RP.]

[Current RP: 4,655]

Eh?

Lloyd received an unexpected achievement notification and a large amount of RP. This was a monumental moment for him as he now had enough RP to use the Time Freeze skill.

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Chapter 288: The Second Key Construction Material (1)

“Eh...?”

Ice Dragon Tyrannus narrowed his eyes in his cave. The cave sat on the rough land beyond the Arctic Sea, south to the Lorasian Continent.

Just what was that?

Tyrannus could feel that the Heart of Winter had vanished. Though it happened in an ever-so-distant land and the item was old, the dragon felt it nonetheless.

A human absorbed it. But... How is that possible?

Tyrannus cocked his head as he recalled the day he gave the Heart of Winter to a human as a gift. It must have been a few hundred years ago. Mikael Magentano, his friend, paved the path of a new era after being touted as the hero among humans. And just as a good friend would do, Tyrannus presented him with a gift. A marble that was infused with his mana and contained the frigid air of winter.

I remember being extremely excited at that time. I got so preoccupied that I produced an artifact more powerful than I originally designed it to be. So powerful that it even possessed a faint consciousness of its own.

Tyrannus had to suffer from a cold that whole year after manufacturing the artifact. But thanks to its devotion and sacrifice, Tyrannus formed a spiritual connection with the Heart of Winter, which was the reason why he could hear the items’ whispers carried by the wind a few days ago.

“The Heart is free.” With that, it was absorbed into a human. This flustered Tyrannus.

Out of all the many races, it had to assimilate into a human’s manaheart. I didn’t know that was even possible.

Tyrannus became curious. It considered flying over where it happened at once, the impulse to satisfy his curiosity surging in him. But he eventually shook his head.

No. I can't ruin my precious time off like this.

Tyrannus objectively analyzed his situation. He was enjoying a restful break after his wife went on a trip with his daughter-in-law. It was a break that had come for the first time in hundreds of years, so a slightly surprising or intriguing incident wasn't going to make him ruin his precious vacation.

Tsk. Who cares. It's not something that's meant to be absorbed. He's going to have an awful stomachache. I guess they did what they had to do. Live or die, it's their business, not mine. Boom!

Boom! Tyrannus resigned and let its head fall flat on the ground, and soon, the soft snoring filled the cave.

♣

At the same hour in Capital Magentano, astonishment filled Lloyd's eyes.

Dang.

Half flustered and satisfied, he hurriedly scanned the message before his eyes like a starving man who was unexpectedly gifted a bowl of ramen in the middle of the night.

It has been a while since I received an accomplishment notification. And the reward is what? 2,000 RP? This is nuts!

Lloyd didn't believe it at first. He wondered if he mistakenly counted an extra zero. He rubbed his eyes and read it again. Still, it read 2,000 RP. Now, he had 4,655 RP.

Haha. Hahaha.

The corners of his lips crawled up on its own. Lloyd instantly knew what he could do with this reward.

I can now use the Time Freeze skill anytime I want to.

Lloyd now held the power to freeze time anywhere except for a zone of his designation. As long as he was in that area, he could carry on with his activities for a year without getting older. Though it was just a year, it was enough time to finish construction of any size.

That's not it. The achievement message explained that the mere excavation of the key material for the jewel's construction is highly impressive and will be remembered throughout history.

That was how he was able to acquire 2,000 RP in one go. And this meant...

From now on, I can receive somewhat similar RP every time I find a key material for this construction.

2,000 RP for every key material found. 3,000 RP for the Time Freeze skill.

So, let's say that I spend 3,000 RP and freeze time. While the world stands still, I can go on and excavate another key material for construction. That'd give me 2,000 RP again. Wow. I feel like I've earned some sort of cash refund.

Of course, there was a big difference of 1,000 RP for both.

But it's all right. 1,000 RP is a manageable amount.

Sure, it was burdensome, but it wasn't impossible. And because it wasn't impossible, he felt encouraged to push ahead with his future plans.

I can save time by using the Time Freeze skill for all future excavations. That will make it easier for me to stop the restoration of destiny.

The more he calculated and made estimations for the future, the happier his humming became. However, he didn't get lost in the rose-colored future.

"Okay, don't loosen up just yet! This is the dangerous part, so pull yourselves together! Push! Two, three!"

“Ppodong!”

“Argh!!!”

Crush! Lloyd’s energetic shout filled the cave, and at his yell, Ppodong and the laborers exerted their efforts, pushing and pulling the piece of tauranga until it was brought outside. As for getting it out to the ground from the vertical cave, that job fell in the mighty hands of Bibeong.

“Okay! Lift it up!”

“Bibeong!”

Despite how the pieces of tauranga were sixteen ft in width and nineteen ft in length, they were just tiny stones to Bibeong. And so, the twelve pieces of the tauranga were soon brought out to the ground under the sun for the first time after hundreds of years. There was more work for Lloyd that followed after, however.

Of course. Since I bored, dug, and opened the area beneath the palace, it’s time to fill it back up.

In the first place, this construction involved boring a giant tunnel under the palace’s foundation.

If I leave the tunnel untouched, it will collapse over time until the whole foundation sinks.

Then, the palace would also collapse as a result since it sat on top of the foundation. Since that was the last thing Lloyd wanted, he shoved rocks and cement into every crevice of the tunnel and refrigerant room, making sure that they were completely filled. And finally, after ten more days, everything was over. The time has come to leave the capital.

Queen Magentano looked at Lloyd. “You are here to greet me farewell before you leave, am I right?”

“That is correct, Your Majesty,” answered Lloyd, bowing his head down.

A wry smile appeared on her face. “Then have you achieved what you came here for?”

“That is also right, Your Majesty,” answered Lloyd.

“Are you not overwhelmed with gratitude?”

“I was just about to add that, Your Majesty.”

“I wouldn’t have hated you at least if you couldn’t talk. And I suppose now is when you’ll ask for my forgiveness.”

Lloyd flinched. “You know me well, Your Majesty...”

“Certainly. Moreover, there is something else.”

“Something else that I need your forgiveness for, Your Majesty?”

“Of course.”

For some reason, he felt that her voice sounded accusatory. “What is that...?”

“Do you still not know?”

Lloyd didn’t know what to say. Here she was suddenly cornering him with her words, but he couldn’t remember what more fault he made. He merely looked up at the queen, who began to click her tongue, which probably was because of his curious gaze.

“Tsk, tsk. A man who only knows about himself and always comes full of empty promises. What a lamentable man you are.”

“Promise, Your Majesty?” Promise? What promise? Lloyd thought to himself as he cocked his head to the side. The wry smile on her face deepened.

“It appears that you have forgotten about your brazen words to me,” reminded the queen. “Do you not remember the conversation we had before

the start of the construction and when you came to request for the Heart of Winter? Do you still not recall what I asked and what you replied?”

“Um... Oh. Right...” It all came back to Lloyd.

“I asked you if you could promise me that your project that involved the usage of the Heart of Winter and harvesting tauranga would not harm my imperial family or me. Do you remember what you said?”

“I said, ‘Certainly, Your Majesty…’”

“I am glad that you have not forgotten your words.”

Lloyd’s face turned red in embarrassment.

“At that time, I naively trusted you with my heart and accepted to grant your request. It was your promise, and I chose to trust you. No other words were necessary. But what happened to that promise?”

Lloyd didn’t say anything but looked down in shame.

“Hmm, how should I get compensated for the destroyed item? What compensation should I demand from a shameless man like yourself.”

“Um, hmm, I profusely ask for your forgive-”

“You are not trying to amend your wrongdoing with mere words, aren’t you?”

“Um, hmm, I truly do not know-”

“You cannot be trying to move on by saying you don’t know how to gain my forgiveness, right?”

“T-then, what is it that Your Majesty wants from-”

“You cannot be asking me to spell that out for you either, right?”

“…”

Please save me, my queen. Or just beat me, scold me, or kill me. Lloyd looked up at the queen with a sullen, gloomy face. This softened her smile.

“It is done. I already declared at the court that I shall not penalize you. So, what need is there to rebuke you now?”

“I am aware, but still...”

“Still?”

Lloyd’s resolute eyes shone as they fixed on her. “I will absolutely return this favor one day, Your Majesty.”

“Favor?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Lloyd hung his head down. This time, he was serious. It wasn’t a joke.

She has been taking great care of me.

In hindsight, it was true. She was always there to give help or assistance during critical moments. This time, too, her help was so priceless that it couldn’t be measured in terms of money. One thing led to another, and he even absorbed the divine item that belonged to the imperial family.

Any ordinary ruler would have seen red. No, they might have been losing sleep trying to think of a way to destroy and kill me on the very day I came to possess powers greater than them.”

But Queen Magentano was different. She instead made him a political comrade with a big heart. And even now, she was showering him with generous assistance and help and supporting his dream of being a rich bum. Not only that, but she also nonchalantly let the incident with the Heart of Winter slide. No one could have a bigger heart than her.

“Therefore, Your Majesty, when you find yourself in trouble, I shall be by your side to overcome it together with you.”

Lloyd spoke sincerely. What he said was against his go-to motto, “Remember what they did for you for a second. Remember what they did to you for life.” But could it be that she wasn’t happy with it? She scoffed.

“Hmm, only once?”

“Your Majesty?!” asked Lloyd in surprise.

“Never mind. Well, once, I see. I should be grateful. This single act of gratitude can’t be easy to obtain from a man who only visits when he wants something from me.”

“...”

“Based on your behaviors to this date, I suppose I should be tearing up in gratitude if you keep it in the future.”

Lloyd gaped in shock.

“So, first, I will only receive your gesture. You can leave now.”

“I am overwhelmed with gratitude, Your Majesty,” replied Lloyd.

“Again. There,” she said as she shook her head. “The gratitude you say only when you are stuck.”

“Um, then, what should I say instead, Your Majesty?”

“Instead of showing me your gratitude, show me your sincerity.”

“Sincerity, Your Majesty?”

“Yes.”

“Then how should I do-”

“That is for you to think and find out. Did you not hear my order that you can leave now?”

“Not at all, Your Majesty. I shall leave now.”

“Tsk. This is the only time you pretend to listen.”

“Your Majesty?”

“I was talking to myself. Do not be curious. So long.”

“Yes, Your Majesty. Long live the queen.”

At last... He was free! Lloyd inwardly yelled in joy as he bolted out of her presence at lightning speed. He swooshed out of the palace and got on the back of Draggy, who was already on standby. Javier, Ppodong, Bangul, and Ggoming were already there.

“So, Bibeong, go back to the Frontera fiefdom. And say bye to Bangul.”

“Bi, Bibeong! Bibeong!”

“Bangul! Bba-bangul!”

Bibeong was, unfortunately, too large to be carried around like the rest of his friends. Moreover, since the Termina Garden was well-repaired, he had no reason to stay in the capital. Bibeong and Bangul parted wistfully as they hugged. And soon, Draggy flew up, its hands tightly clenching the twelve pieces of tauranga.

Fwoosh! Crash! Once it soared up, it turned northward, its fierce fluttering leaving a shockwave. At almost a supersonic speed, they headed north. After several hours of flight, they arrived at the Arctic Sea.

There, Lloyd ordered, “Drop!”

Clack! Splash! Draggy dropped the Taurangas from 10,000 feet above. They sank into the sea. Lloyd waited until they hit the water and plunged down to the foundation where the Jewel of Truth would be built. Soon, a welcoming message emerged.

Ding dong.

[You have dropped the twelve pieces of tauranga safely near the foundation of the Jewel of Truth.]

[For this, you now can access information on the Taupo, the second key material for the Jewel of Truth.]

[Would you like to access information on the Taupo now?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a yes.

Lloyd silently nodded. Just then...

Fwoosh! A new video emerged and clouded his vision.

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Chapter 289: The Second Key Construction Material (2)

Ruuumble...!

Dozens of horses foamed at the mouths, their muscular necks, chests, and bodies sweating in buckets. The shouts and orders to pull harder rang aloud the area, mixed with the knights' commands, laborers' shouts, and stifled neighing. As a dust storm emerged, there was a giant staircase made of stone being carried forward. It wasn't a simple and sleek staircase. The inside of the stairs where the steps of stone met had something resembling a speed bump. The bump had a unique shape. It was designed to connect to the stone beside it. Dozens of horses dragged the staircase along with countless other spoils.

Knights marched on with victorious smiles on their faces after having survived the destructive battlefield and war that marked the end of the mythical age. The procession was making its way toward their home, the land of the humans, when something happened.

Fwish! Stab! An arrow flew and stabbed a knight's forehead. It was followed by a salvo of arrows, all aimed at the horses, knights, and laborers. Chaos descended the land. Screams were heard. Amid the chaos and painful shrieks, the knights prepared for a counterattack in rage. This rage was directed toward themselves for allowing this ambush to happen by lowering their guards and to their enemies for their sneak attack. They flew into a rage and raised their spears and swords, confident that they were unrivaled in the entire continent. There wasn't a single creature who could ever defeat them while they rode their horses. Their confidence was absolute and passionate.

But their beliefs weren't entirely groundless. It was the truth that no creature ever managed to strike them down in a mobile warfare on a plain. There were countless armies and monsters that had been helplessly defeated and died at their hands. And thus, they earned the saying, "one with the horse." Brimming with assurance that victory would come like so many other times, they charged forward. Yet, they faced defeat.

The issue was that they were only described to be one with their horses, whereas their enemies were actually part animal. Their lower torsos were that of a strong, wild horse, and their upper torsos were that of a human body. This perfect bodily combination assured a level of speed and maneuver no cavalry could ever come close to. Rapid acceleration. Rapid stops. Rapid turns. Unrestrained speed control. The half-horse and half-human creatures wreaked havoc, using their spears to stab, kicking with their hind legs, and shooting arrows when they had a chance. And with that, the continent's greatest knights met its doom.

Terrified, the laborers ran for their lives while their enemies celebrated their easy win by stealing the stone staircase. They tied the ropes around the stones with sweat dripping down their body as they galloped toward the vast plain of the northwest.

A long time had passed since then. The world had changed. A new chapter of history had begun, and the story had become a legend. The existence of the staircase had faded away with the passage of time. With that, the video had ended.

Ding dong.

[You have finished accessing the information on the Taupo staircase, the second key material of the Jewel of Truth used to build its staircase.]

[If you wish to watch it again, please select "Replay."]

"Whew." Lloyd exhaled the breath he'd been holding for a while. This video reminded him of the VR experience he had once back in Korea. And so, he was amused and also felt nostalgic thinking about his past.

Ah, I wish I could watch a movie, a drama, or even a MeTube video.

Just then, a desire to watch a film came over him. He wanted to sprawl around on his sofa or floor, binge-watching movies, dramas, and variety shows for several hours as he flipped through different channels. He missed the mere act of mindlessly watching something entertaining. Lloyd became

wretchedly nostalgic of it since it was an enjoyment unavailable in this world.

Tsk. The records of the mythical age didn't have to be pretentious by showing me a video. It's just making me want to watch TV.

Lloyd grumbled to himself but didn't forget to mentally go through the contents he had just seen.

The Jewel of Truth. The second key material of the Aotearoa was the stone staircase.

The video featured a giant staircase with distinctive bumps at its end. It was something Lloyd was familiar with.

Suppose tauranga was the material used in building the holding stones for the Tomb of the General. The Taupo would be the first flight of stairs at the far bottom of the Tomb of the General. Its structure and basic principles are very similar.

The more he thought about it, the more it was the case. Since the Tomb of the General was made of blocks of stones, it was gigantic and massive. As such, how to safely distribute the weight was the biggest task he had when it came to building it.

Thus, the holding stones and the first flight of stairs played a big part in managing its weight. The holding stones were placed on all four sides of the Tomb of the General as if they were spalled on. They prevented lateral pressure from centering to the bottom of the building. As for the first flight of stairs...

They, too, had a purpose. *Its bump structure is interconnected with the stones next to it. Like putting arms around each other's shoulders. Should I say that it was meant to withhold the weight pressing down from the top and distributing it around? That was how the Tomb of the General managed without its lower structure crumbling under its weight.*

The shape of the Taupo in the video held a striking resemblance with the first flight of stairs in the Tomb of the General.

And as for the race that ambushed the knights...

Lloyd, who was still 10,000 feet above the ground on Draggy's back, thought about the ambushers.

Yeah, they're definitely centaurs.

Centaurs were half-human and half-horse creatures. They were equestrian by nature, and the plains were their running ground. They were born to gallop, and at times, gave their lives away for it. They were the creatures that made you wonder how they scratched their backs or stomachs.

Anyway, the centaurs took the second key construction material.

Lloyd sighed at length after reaching the conclusion. The Great War was said to have seen participation from all sorts of races, and now, it was the centaurs. Really?

The setting for this novel sucks.

Lloyd was condemning the author of the novel when he heard Javier's voice.

"Did you see something this time again?"

When Lloyd turned, he found Javier shooting a cold, cynical gaze typical of him.

"Yeah." Lloyd nodded. "I saw a video record."

Lloyd didn't bother to lie about the video. There was no need to. This pertained to the legendary artifact of the mythical age. Getting clues from a magical vision wasn't anything suspicious.

Plus, he won't doubt me if I'm honest with him about these small events.

Lloyd thought that he shouldn't hide it from A to Z and make hardly believable excuses for everything. He believed he ought to be frank about the minor details since he hid his identity from Javier.

That way, Javier won't be skeptical about my important matters. He'll trust me.

And besides, Javier wasn't a slow guy. Lloyd didn't want Javier to find out about him first before he bore his heart out to Count and Countess Frontera. Part of it was because of fear. Lloyd was scared that Javier might point his sword at him for faking his identity and abusing him for all these years once he found out.

And so, Lloyd decided to be shameless. "I've seen the events after the Great War. The knights were ambushed when they were taking the stone staircase, the second key material for this construction, as a spoil of war."

"Ambush? What do you mean?"

"The centaurs attacked the knights and took the staircase from them."

Javier stroked his chin. "Then I suppose our next destination is the Great Plain in the northwest."

"Right," affirmed Lloyd. "That's where we are heading."

Lloyd was glad that the centaurs' habitat was widely known, like the merpeople. They lived in the great plains of the highlands located in the northwest. The climate here was similar to the highlands in Mongolia.

It's cold because it's located inland and sits quite high in altitude. The area is unimaginably cold and dry, making it barely habitable. Farming is difficult there too. Thanks to this, no kingdom covets the land.

It was just a cold and dry neighborhood with barely any arable land whose inhabitants were powerful centaurs. The place was hard to take over, and even if it was taken over, it was barely useful. Thanks to these factors, no one lusted after the land. It was absolutely free from trespassing humans

and invading kingdoms. That was how the land managed to solely be used by the centaurs to this day.

“So, let’s go,” urged Lloyd, “Draggy.”

Clack!

Draggy precisely understood Lloyd’s message. It changed its flight direction toward the south and removed itself from the Arctic Sea. Past the northern end of the continent, the scenery beneath Lloyd’s feet started to change. The forests in the tundra and taiga flashed past, the treetops covered with snow. And the giant mountain range stood tall, its height shooting up from the bottom enough to touch Lloyd’s feet. And once they passed several peaks, at last, the highlands as high as 8,200 feet spanned in front of his eyes. It was the Great Plain, the largest highland in the northwest area. Lloyd urged Draggy to land at the entrance.

“Draggy. Play here for a while.”

Creak?

“I’m sorry,” apologized Lloyd. “I fear that the folks in this area will panic when they see you. They might think we’re invading. But don’t cock your head like that. You’re making me feel guilty.”

Claaack!

“No, no. People don’t hate you because you’re ugly. They don’t hate you. Um, so... I don’t know. Just make sure you’re hiding in the woods and hang around here. Got it?”

Clack!

Draggy nodded but not without casting a discouraged look at Lloyd. He smiled apologetically. He felt bad, but there wasn’t anything he could do.

Draggy looks too menacing on the outside. It’ll easily ruin the first encounter we have with the nearby centaurs. I feel bad, but there’s nothing I can do. I should play ball with it next time.

Resolved to appease Draggy in the future, Lloyd went into the vast plain with Javier, both riding on Ppodong's back. After about three or four hours of galloping and enjoying the endless stretch of the plain...

"Something is coming this way."

Javier, who was seated at the back, pointed to one area. Lloyd turned and found several dots dancing on the horizon, coming close toward him. No, it was charging at him. The dots grew in size. Sandstorms raged behind their trails. At last, they came close and surrounded Lloyd and Javier.

"Stop! The stranger should stop at once right now!"

Gallop! Thwack! They circled around Lloyd, and the noise of the galloping footsteps menacingly drummed in his ears. These centaurs were clad in dark-brown armor over their muscular human torso and armed with spears and arrows. Their tail manes on their horse body swayed sideways, and their gazes glimmered icily. These centaurs belonged to the patrol team.

Woah. Look at their muscles beneath their armors.

Lloyd studied the centaurs surrounding him. He counted about twenty in total. Every one of them exuded power and strength. Although they'd be an easy opponent against Javier, Lloyd got the impression that they were stubborn as a mule apart from their actual strength.

Looks like folks in this neighborhood are hostile to humans too.

It looked like they were seconds away from hurling sharp arrows or spears into his heart if he slighted them or ignored their warning.

Well. That should be how they managed to protect their land for hundreds and thousands of years from human invasion.

Lloyd understood them very well and simultaneously found a way to break their stubbornness.

"What will you do?" Javier softly spoke beside him. He was standing in front of Lloyd as if he was preparing for a possible confrontation. Javier's

voice was calm.

Lloyd grinned at him. “What do you mean? There’s no need for confrontation.”

Really. There was no need for unnecessary confrontation with the patrol team. He had no reason for it. There was a softer, healthier, and more effective way to sort this out.

“So, excuse me for a second, Javier.” Lloyd slipped in front of Javier.

Swish! Lloyd’s movement immediately brought the twenty spears to glint and aim at him. But Lloyd didn’t even bat an eye. Instead, he casually spoke up, recalling the story he read in the novel, and suggested a method that would win their hearts and access to their land in one go.

“Hello, my name is Lloyd Frontera. I heard that you are the fastest runners on land. I want to see if that’s actually true. Is there anyone here who is faster than me?”

“……!”

This suggestion took them by surprise. It was an explicit provocation and challenge. Everyone’s eyes immediately held a glint of instinct competitiveness. They were offended by the man’s daring challenge. They boasted that they were the reckless runners of the vast plain, the only ones who could so rapidly take off, halt, turn, and freely increase and decrease their speed and change sides. How dare a human challenge us, they thought.

“Fine. I will race you.” The patrol commander came out with ease. Pointing at the small rock and laughing at Lloyd, he said, “Start at the same time. The one who gets to the rock first wins.”

“Awesome.” Lloyd got on Ppodong’s back and stood at the start line with the patrol leader. At last, the signal came.

“Go!”

Gallop! Sprint! Sprint! The centaur and Ppodong raced as they created a dust storm all over the area. And about fifteen seconds later...

Slap! A red speeding ticket, which allowed access to the vast plain, was stuck on Lloyd’s back.

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Chapter 290: Reckless Driving is Bad (1)

The Grassland of Wind and Stone was the central area of the Great Plain as it was the hometown of all the centaurs. There, residents witnessed a spectacular sight.

“I-It’s a red speeding ticket!” One of the young centaurs shouted. Everyone’s gaze immediately focused on one place. Then they saw.

“It really is. It’s really a red speeding ticket.”

“My goodness...”

“I never imagined I’d see one in my lifetime.”

“But it’s not on one of us but a human.”

“Maybe it’s fake?”

“No, that is not possible. Only the patrol commander protecting the outskirts of the Great Plain can issue that ticket.”

“Hold on,” one gasped. “Does that mean... that human galloped faster than the patrol commander?”

“What else could it mean?” A senile centaur replied.

Everyone gulped at it. And they took another glance at the human with a red ticket on his back. He wasn't ordinary outside. He was a human outsider. And now, he was confidently striding across the village center, flashing a red speeding ticket. The goggled-eyed centaurs gaped as they beheld the scene. Lloyd, who was receiving the awe-filled attention, smiled.

This feels like I’ve become a celebrity.

It really was the case. At first, the centaurs were astonished by the appearance of an outsider. Then their astonishment grew when they saw the red speeding ticket on his back. After some chaotic, confusing, and doubtful

moments, they realized that the ticket was real and gazed at Lloyd with admiration. Their manner was similar to the fangirls of VTS when they bumped into their idol.

Of course, it wasn't easy to get this ticket.

Two days ago, Lloyd arrived at the entrance of the plane and was confronted by a patrol group. At that moment, he challenged them to a race by arguing that he was faster than them. The bold suggestion immediately brought the patrol leader to come forth. A drag race was held.

Seven seconds.

Seven seconds after they left the start line, Ppodong came in half a foot earlier than the patrol commander. Ppodong was equivalent to a vehicle with a V-8 5,000 cc natural engine, and the patrol commander burst with admiration toward Ppodong.

It looked like he was going to burst into tears right after he crossed the finish line.

Was it because he was indignant about his defeat? No. It was tears of overwhelming admiration, the kind only a speed-obsessive nut-job would show in the presence of a faster being. And thankfully, Lloyd was able to get a hold of a red speeding ticket.

"There is no insignia more glorious than this red speeding ticket. It was an honor to have galloped with you. May you have a safe and enjoyable stay here..."

And just like that, Lloyd acquired permission from the patrol commander. The speeding ticket was a pass that granted access to anywhere in the Centaurian territory. And the red ticket was the highest honor he could attain. It was quite literally a symbol of glory. This had much to do with the character of the centaurs.

They are wild horses racing through the plains.

And that was why they regarded galloping as the most crucial skill to have, and everyone yearned to be the fastest. Just like how South Korean society idolized one's money-making capacity, the Centaurian society valued the ability to run fast above anything else. The fastest individual was regarded as the most capable, and the slowest individual received pitiful tongue clicks from others. These horse-humans were obsessed with speed.

So, the ability to rapidly start running and stopping is just a basic skill they learn. And their quick turns and boundless control of speed are something they learn when they're young.

What would happen if the centaurs were born in South Korea? They'd overspeed nonstop and violently drive around, changing lanes without a signal until they eventually became an avid collector for speeding and traffic-light-violation tickets. Anyway, due to their propensity, Lloyd received a wide welcome from the five villages he passed through until he arrived at the territory of the Stone and Wind tribe.

I even met a tribal chief who pleaded with me to marry his daughter.

Lloyd had been shocked by the incident, only to be gobsmacked once again when the centaur lady wailed after seeing that Lloyd had two legs instead of four.

The heck with lookism!

Crack! Lloyd pushed his memories of the past two days away from his head. And he walked over to the centaurs who were gazing at him with respect and admiration.

"Um, I just have a question to ask," said Lloyd in a careful voice.

"Yes! Ask anything!"

"Me! Ask me!"

"Mister! I can answer you better!"

At Lloyd’s question, three centaurs, who were each young, female, and middle-aged, battled to answer him first. Lloyd suppressed his smile. “Oh, yes, thank you. But I’m not asking for just one answer. Anyone who can give me an answer is welcome to.”

“Understood! What do you want to know?”

“Me! I’ll answer it for you!”

“Ehem! I said I can answer you properly!”

“Ahaha...” laughed Lloyd awkwardly. “Yes, thank you. The thing is, I’m looking for this stone.”

Flap! Lloyd brought out a piece of paper from his pocket. It was a detailed illustration of the Taupo he had drawn on his way over here.

“The size is about 26, 19, and 3.9 feet, respectively, in width, length, and height. And there’s a unique bump as you can see here at the end. Have you seen a stone like this one around here?”

“Eek! No, I didn’t! I’m sorry!”

“Waa! I want to see it too! I want to say my answer, too!”

“Shucks! I’ll go find it right away! Just wait here!”

Despite everyone’s enthusiastic response, nothing satisfied Lloyd.

Tsk. I suppose it’s been too long since the Taupo was brought here.

Lloyd smacked his lips in bitterness. It was like this at the Mermaid Kingdom as well. No one barely remembered the whereabouts of the Jewel of Truth because too much time had passed.

And it’s not like I can survey the whole area.

Lloyd looked around. There was a seemingly endless stretch of land everywhere he looked. Just like the name of the plain, this land was too vast

and expansive. And so, he felt even more stuck.

No. It's too early to tell. I should ask around some more.

Lloyd made the decision. He would continue to ask people around. He asked every centaur he met about the Taupo. And at last, thanks to his efforts, he was able to finally get the answer that interested him.

"Oh! I know what that is! Someone said that the tribal chief head knows all about the old stories!" a kid centaur hurriedly answered. And he pointed his foal horseshoe to the center of the tribe.

"The head of the tribal chief lives there! I will take you there!"

"Oh, sure. That's kind of you."

Lloyd then followed the child centaur. The house of the tribal chief head wasn't anything spectacular. It was like the rest of the centaurs. A typical tent stable. But his appearance was far from typical.

"Welcome, a human with a red speeding ticket. I have been following the stirs among the tribe members." His voice was grave and solemn. But his appearance was a complete contrast to the gravity and seriousness in his tone.

Damn.

Lloyd sucked in his breath as soon as he saw the head chief standing in front of him. Despite his senility, he was extremely muscular, his fur shaved up in a flashy manner. It made his skin look like a tattoo. No, to be more exact...

That's it. The car stickers that car aficionados stick all over their four wheels. Those kinds of decorations. There are even patterns with fire, lightning bolts, and eagles, tigers, or skeletons and hearts! The whole collection, I say.

Without any exaggeration, the head chief's body was a sketchbook of tattoos. From his lower horse torso to his upper human torso, tattoos

covered his whole body, excluding his face and nape. And all the piercings in his ears, nose, and lips! The long hair that flowed down him like a hippie's made him give off a free-spirited vibe.

He even got his horseshoe modified. It's sharp and pointy. One kick from that, and I'm going to be diced like a pork cutlet.

In many ways, his appearance was extraordinary, befitting his status as the head chief of the speedy tribes. Thanks to that, Lloyd had to quickly manage his facial expression as he was greeted by the chief.

Hmm... Looks like he lived a wild life in his youth.

But it didn't matter if he was one of the gang members racing around back in his days. Lloyd had a business to take care of. Clearing his throat, Lloyd politely said, "I am honored to be in the presence of the owner of the tribe of the great plain."

"Haha. Not only do you possess such an incredible ticket, but you're also humble on top of it. It's nice to meet you. My name is Cherokan, the head chief that is leading the centaurs."

"Oh, yes."

Head Chief Cherokan welcomed him, and his manners were so open and hospitable without any hint of suspicion or trickery. Encouraged by the chief, Lloyd openly revealed the purpose of his visit.

"Chief," said Lloyd, "Thank you for welcoming me. The thing is, I am here to search for an item called the Taupo."

"Taupo?"

"Yes, it's an object your ancestors brought during the mythical age."

"Um, the mythical age? Are you looking for what was taken from the Jewel of Truth?"

“Oh, yes. That’s exactly it.” Feeling that things are going somewhere fast, Lloyd hopefully said, “Do you happen to know, chief, where the Taupo is at?”

“I do.” Chief Cherokan made a knowing smile.

“Then can you tell me where-”

“Nope.”

“Excuse me?”

“I know, but I cannot tell you.” The rejection was as straightforward as his big-hearted attitude.

Flailing his nostrils, Lloyd uttered, “Why... can’t you tell me?”

“Because I don’t want to.”

For a second, a sudden impulse to grab him by the neck or make him listen by force surged in Lloyd. He had to suppress his desire, however.

Is he playing with me or what? Should I force it out of him? No. Mobilizing Javier or Draggy will do the job, but I might regret it in the future.

Lloyd shook his head and looked back on his experience.

I have to find the key material for the Jewel of Truth. Knowing where it is might not be enough. What if I force things around here and antagonize the entire tribe? What if I can’t get cooperation from them when I need it? I might be in big trouble.

When he set out to find the Jewel of Truth and look for tauranga, the merpeople, and the queen were a massive source of help. Lloyd received a feeling that it might be the same this time.

So, let’s act with discretion. Life is longer than you think, and you never know what will happen. That’s why it’s important to have connections.

Just then, Lloyd recalled his days in room rental. He had no close family or other relatives around him. All of his parent's acquaintances and distant relatives cut him off the moment they learned about their drastic decision. No one offered to help. He had lost all his connections.

And because of their drastic absence, I was able to feel how important social connections are to humans. It's the same now. Once I build a good relationship with the head chief and centaur tribes, it's going to benefit me in some sort of way. Throwing away such a good opportunity isn't a smart choice.

And so, he decided to be on good terms with the chief. Approach things with utmost extra care. Resolved, Lloyd said, "Then, Chief Cherokan..."

"Speak."

"Is there anything you want from me?"

"Finally," blurted the chief, "You are talking. I surely got one. And if you give me what I want, then I should be able to resolve your curiosity."

As I thought, he was saying nothing is free.

It was the same in both the world of humans and centaurs. Meanwhile, Cherokan spoke. "I am hoping you could solve a worry of mine."

"What do you mean?"

"The youth of my race. The children. Their hot-blooded and reckless behavior is giving me a headache."

"Hot-blooded and reckless behavior?"

"Yes," Cherokan sighed softly. "You must be well aware of it. How much my race loves speed. How we worship speed. And so, we race even for marriage proposals. Only the fastest, male or female, can marry the desired partner."

"Um, so?"

“It’s a problem. The over competitiveness is causing too many accidents.

“Um, is it because they are speeding?”

“That’s exactly right. The violent race, things like overspeeding, changing lanes, hostile driving... All these put the lives of themselves and others in a risky situation. That’s why a large number of our youth are getting hurt and becoming disabled.”

“Then...”

“Why not stop them from violently racing each other, you ask?” interrupted Cherokan preemptively. “I can’t. It’s not something you can stop. Running is a part of our instinct. It’s not something to be stopped. That is why I am racking my head here, figuring out a way for the young centaurs to run freely and let their instincts run wild more safely than now.”

“Um, that’s what you were worried about?”

“Yes.” Cherokan nodded.

Lloyd nodded after hearing him. “That’s a simple concern.”

“What? Simple?”

“Yes.”

It really was a simple problem. Lloyd chuckled. The moment he heard his concern, Lloyd immediately came up with the answer he had in mind. “How about putting up a circuit-shaped coliseum for them to race?”

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Chapter 291: Reckless Driving is Bad (2)

“How about putting up a circuit-shaped coliseum for racing?”

“Excuse me?” Head Chief Cherokan cocked his head to the side at the smiling Lloyd. It was a strange and new suggestion. “Coliseum? A circuit for racing? What does that mean?”

“Simply put,” Lloyd explained, “It’s a stadium solely for speed racing.”

“A stadium? It’s a stadium meant to hold a race?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded, thinking that things were going somewhere. The chief was intrigued and expressed his curiosity just enough. Lloyd realized that he should strike when the iron was still hot. And so, he rattled on, “It’s a space reserved for running, and everyone can watch safely as it happens. The participants will be able to gallop without any interruption.”

“Hmm.” Cherokan mused. “A stadium… A space for anyone to run without restraint. Are you saying that is the solution to my problem?”

“Yes, chief.”

“What makes you say that? What’s your argument?” The chief frowned.

Adding another layer of shamelessness to his face, Lloyd said, “Chief, you’ve told me how worried you are about the young centaurs running recklessly around and getting into accidents, big and small, while racing one another to win someone’s hand in marriage.”

“I did.”

“Exactly,” Lloyd said intently. “You’ve also said that you’re sorry to see these accidents killing or disabling those youths who would otherwise have had a bright future ahead of them. So imagine what it would be like if the young centaurs could freely gallop to their heart’s content in a stadium specially designed for running?”

“Hmm, you mean that there would be fewer accidents since they’d only gallop at full speed in a safe, designated area?”

“That’s right, chief.”

Despite Lloyd’s confidence, Cherokan looked hardly convinced. “But you seem to be forgetting something, my friend.”

“What is it, chief?” asked Lloyd.

“As you already know, we’ve lived our whole lives running wherever our hearts desired. Do you truly believe that we would be willing to only race inside a stadium? That won’t happen. Even with a stadium, we will still choose a random location to hold competitions, challenge each other, and race to determine who is faster. It’s just not in our blood to let someone run ahead of us.”

“Yes, I am aware of that, chief,” Lloyd replied. “That’s where the rules come in.”

“Rules?”

“Yes.”

“What rules?” The chief’s eyes sharpened.

Lloyd spoke as if the answer was obvious. “We will set a speed limit in certain locations.”

“Set a speed limit?”

“Yes. It’s simple. We’ll state that they can only trot in village areas, but the meadows are a free racing zone. That would be all the limits they need to comply with.”

“But that’s problematic,” Cherokan insisted.

“Why is that?”

“If meadows have no speed limits, then that renders the stadium unnecessary.”

“You’re right, but that can be solved with one extra regulation.”

“Which is?”

“To designate the coliseum as the only venue for holding marriage-related races.”

“So courtship competitions can only happen there...?”

“That is exactly it.” Lloyd could sense that the chief was starting to come around. It was now time for Lloyd to bring up the crux of the matter. “The most dangerous races are those for someone’s hand in marriage. Was that not the case with you, chief?”

“Hmm... Come to think of it, yes. I think so. It applied to my own proposal. I remember my competitiveness peaked at that age. It was so powerful that it was blinding. I successfully proposed after giving my all to win the race.”

“I figured. That’s also why it’s dangerous.” Lloyd pointed out.

That’s the way it is. It’s the same whether you’re a centaur or human.

A competition for someone’s hand in marriage. Such a race would naturally be fiercer than usual. That was easily understandable if you compared it to bar fights.

I’ve often seen similar instances in my country. Whenever guys start arguing with other guys at another table, all of them surprisingly play nice and try to move on because they don’t want to get into an unnecessary fight. Well, unless you’re a sadist who enjoys violence. However, there are exceptions.

It was when the guys were with girls.

The chances of a simple scuffle developing into something big were significantly higher.

In those situations, men suddenly loved to act tough and masculine before their love interests as they didn't want to appear weak. They yielded less and regarded backing off as defeat, and would ultimately spoil the atmosphere of the bar with their heightened stubbornness and aggression.

It's super childish and ridiculous. But it can't be helped even if they'll obviously regret their behavior in the future.

It occurred surprisingly frequently. At least based on Lloyd's observation.

A real man should maintain reason and deal with the situation tactfully. But that's easier said than done. The centaurs are quite similar. Even the novel mentions that these creatures become the most aggressive during marriage-related matters.

Lloyd recalled the story in the novel. It was a short explanation of the centaurs and how their innate love for speed and racing dramatically spiked when there was a potential marriage at stake. The only thing in their sight was victory and marrying their desired partner. It wasn't uncommon for them to risk their lives.

If you think about it, it actually makes sense. I'd do the same. If I've got a competitor for the girl I want to marry, I'd obviously run like a madman. I wouldn't care what's ahead of me. I'd just run to cross the finish line first without a second thought.

Come hell or high water, the finish line would be the only thing in sight, and he would become blind to his surroundings, endangering himself and others around him.

"So," Lloyd went on, "We'll create a space exclusively for that reckless race for love. We'll build a circuit-style coliseum."

"Do you think that will reduce the number of accidents?"

"I believe it will. After all, the centaurs running at full speed will be separated from the other runners."

It was the same case in a modern society like South Korea. There was a reason why highways existed apart from other roads.

There's a notable example of this in Germany. The Autobahn. The road meant for drivers to speed on.

There were also similar places in South Korea. For instance, there was a circuit located in Inje County of the Gangwon Province.

The furrow between the head chief's eyebrows deepened. Could it be that the chief somewhat understood Lloyd's intention?

"I see what you mean. In short, you want to designate certain areas for different purposes. That's why you're suggesting this coliseum."

"Yes, chief. Inside the village, everyone will have to trot slowly. In the meadow, they can canter or gallop. And only at the coliseum can they recklessly race over love."

Cherokan nodded in understanding. "Good. I believe the number of tragic accidents will decrease if everyone follows these regulations."

"It certainly looks like it."

"Indeed. But... I am doubtful that my centaurs will follow your suggestions." Chief Cherokan's eyes faltered as they fixed on Lloyd. "As excellent as your ideas are, I can't help but think they're unrealistic. The question is whether these instinctive runners would willfully confine themselves and obey all the stifling rules. I personally do not think so."

"You mean they'll choose their right to freely gallop over their own safety."

"Yes." Chief Cherokan nodded. "The desire to gallop and race each other may be something humans will never be able to grasp fully. But that's who we are. We'd rather die than be forbidden to run."

"Hmm." Lloyd stroked his chin.

“So, you can expect no young centaur to ever follow your rules if you designate a no-gallop zone and restrict areas for courtship races. They will ignore or protest with a scoff. That’s how intense their running instinct is.”

“Hmm...”

“Moreover,” Chief Cherokan went on, “This is about tradition. Starting from our earliest ancestors, we’ve lived freely around the land. That’s our traditional way of life. And your recommendations suggest changing that precedent.”

“Hmm...”

“And that is why, even if I like your suggestion, I’m not confident they will take up on it. Everyone will oppose it. There’s no reason for them to follow the rules.”

“Hmmmm...”

“My friend, why are you looking at me strangely?” asked Chief Cherokan.

“Oh, yes,” replied Lloyd. “It’s because I feel like I’m looking at a motorcycle gang that is desperately giving excuses to defend themselves.”

“A motorcycle gang?”

“Yes. Well. Something like that.” A chuckle escaped Lloyd. He couldn’t help it.

It’s like he’s telling me that they can’t help being carefree souls, and it’s not any of my business whether they live or die while running.

That was the impression Lloyd got after hearing Chief Cherokan’s explanation of the nature of centaurs.

Well. A speeding ticket being their glorious symbol already says a lot about them.

Of course, Lloyd couldn’t care less about whether these chronic speeders got killed or injured from recklessly racing. That would have been his normal reaction. But not now.

Chief said he’d tell me where Taupo was if I helped him develop a solution for safety. So I’ve got to create one for them.

Lloyd decided. He would help them improve safety. So he began to rack his brain, going over a list of possible things he could do and how they might be received. Once Lloyd finished doing the math in his head, he looked straight into the chief’s eyes. “How about this, chief? If you’re not confident you could persuade them, then I’ll do it for you.”

“You? You’ll persuade them?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“You do not need to worry about that. I’ll just ask you one thing. If I get the centaurs to comply with the regulations and build the coliseum, can you promise me you’ll tell me where the Taupo is?”

That was the moment for him to push back. Lloyd’s voice swelled with confidence. Thankfully, it didn’t take a long time until the chief spoke.

“Fine... I promise, if you can persuade everyone to follow the planned regulations.”

“Very well,” Lloyd said. “Let’s take care of this then.”

Flap! Lloyd pulled out a piece of paper from his pocket once the chief nodded. Like a spider detecting food on its web or a python spotting its meal for the day, Lloyd held out a piece of paper without giving any time for Cherokan to react.

“This paper details the promises you’ve just made, chief. So why don’t we draw up two contracts? One for me and another for you.”

“Contracts...?”

“Yes.” Lloyd beamed and spoke nonchalantly. “It’s always better to handle these matters with as much clarity as possible. Oh, don’t get me wrong. I’m not doing this because I can’t trust you, chief. It’s the opposite. What if I go back on my words? These pieces of paper will help us establish healthy and mutual trust.”

“...”

Gulp. Chief Cherokan wondered for a second whether he was in the presence of a scammer. He had spent his whole life living a simple life in the meadows and couldn’t help having such a suspicion. Despite his anxiety, they soon signed and finalized the contract at the speed of light.

“Okay, please write your name here. The date. Your signature. All right. Just stamp right over here.”

“...”

“Oh my, look at that. That was a perfectly placed stamp,” praised Lloyd. “As I thought, you can really assess someone’s disposition by seeing how they sign a contract. I can tell you’re a considerate, meticulous, and cheerful centaur from this. And you’re obviously popular among centaurs, both male and female, because of your thoughtfulness.”

“I-Is that so?” muttered Chief Cherokan.

“Yes. I’m not trying to blow my own trumpet, but I’m a very good judge of character.”

“Ehem! Ehem! Come to think of it, you’re right. Hahaha.”

“Right? I’ve read you correctly, chief.”

“Hahaha! Thank you!”

“Well then, I shall be going now. I’ll come back once I persuade your tribe members.”

Lloyd smiled as he rose up. The contract was signed. It was over. Lloyd bolted out of the place before the nice mood he worked so hard to create turned sour. When he walked out of the stable, he was greeted by Javier who had been waiting nearby.

“Are you done talking to him?” asked Javier.

“Yeah. You heard most of the conversation, right?

“Yes.” Javier nodded as he walked beside Lloyd. “But that is why I am more confused. I cannot understand why you would build a coliseum for them and make the tribe follow the safety regulations.”

“Why? Is it strange?”

“Yes.”

“In what way?”

“As far as I am concerned, I do not think anyone will obey it.”

“Yes, you’re probably right.” Lloyd didn’t hesitate to confirm Javier’s opinion.

Lloyd felt the stinging gaze from Javier. Javier finally asked, “I am probably right? You speak as though you already have an idea what will happen.”

“Yeah,” acknowledged Lloyd. “I do.”

He really did. Lloyd was already aware of how the centaurs would react even before he suggested the coliseum project and safety regulations to the chief.

“Then I suppose you have a secret plan in mind?” asked Javier.

“Uh-huh.”

“May I ask what that is?”

“Yeah. Sure. I’m going to run a safe racing campaign and provoke the entire tribe.”

“Provoke the entire tribe, Young Master?” Javier tilted his head in confusion.

“It means I plan to piss everyone off,” Lloyd said cheerfully.

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Chapter 292: Reckless Driving is Bad (3)

Four days passed. All the while, a strange rumor went around among the centaurs in the Stone and Wind tribe.

“Honey, did you hear about that human?” a centaur wife asked her husband.

“Human? Who?”

“The one who arrived here a few days ago.”

“Oh, the man with the red speeding ticket?” asked the male centaur. “What was his name? Lloyd Frontera?”

“Yes, that’s right,” she affirmed. “Lloyd Frontera. He told me he’s going to give a lecture.”

“A lecture?”

“Uh-huh.”

“About what?”

“I think it’s an in-depth lecture about speeding or whatever.”

“Are you serious?” He lifted his brow.

“Yes. Honey, you were getting anxious that your hind leg isn’t as strong as it used to be.”

“Hmm, yes,” he acknowledged. “I fear my stamina isn’t as great as before.”

“So…” she said as she clapped her hands. “How about you go and listen to the lecture?”

“Do you think it will help?”

“Of course. You have nothing to lose by attending. While you’re at it, take the kids with you.”

“Why?”

“You should know how important early education is these days,” she said strongly.

“Hm, you know what? You are right,” he agreed. “The man earned a red speeding ticket as a mere human. He must know the secret to getting faster, right?”

“I’m sure he does. I hope our kids become great foals that get red speeding tickets.”

“Of course,” he said. “You are wise, indeed.”

At the same time…

“Boss! We have a situation!” A young centaur charged into a stable.

“What? What is it?” His boss asked in surprise.

“Well, do you remember the human who got a red speeding ticket? He’s giving a lecture.”

“On what?”

“They say it’s going to be about something called speeding!” The young one’s voice sounded frantic.

“Ha...” the boss centaur sighed. “Are you sure?”

“Yes.”

“That’s a big problem.”

“Isn’t it? I’m afraid his galloping method will be similar to ours, and he will teach it to others.”

“I agree. That tactic should remain a secret amongst ourselves.”

“Should we apply for a patent?” asked the young one carefully.

“Hmm... When’s the lecture?”

“The day after tomorrow.”

“Tsk. It’ll be too late by then. We won’t have enough time to get a review,” said the boss.

“Then what do we do?”

“Let’s go to the lecture. We should listen to what that human has to say about this speeding matter.”

“Yes, boss. Do you want us to put our names on the attendance list?”

“Yes, put everyone down.”

“I must have heard wrong. All of the members?” The young centaur was surprised by his boss’s eagerness.

“Of course. The galloping members and the maintenance team as well. Even if his theory is different from ours, I’m sure we can glean one or two lessons from him.”

“Yes, I see, boss.”

A similar conversation also took place among the younger centaurs. The rumor didn’t stop there. It spread further outside of the Stone and Wind tribe and across the plain.

“Chief! The human who received a red speeding ticket from the Stone and Wind tribe is giving a lecture!”

“This is our chance. The human’s theory of speeding must be different from ours, so we’ll no doubt learn something new from him!”

“Let us go!”

“Faster now!”

“Quickly now!”

“Nothing can stop us!”

A total of 21 centaur tribes, including the Rock Wild Grass, Deer Cloud, Mushroom and Creek, and Dew and Stake tribes, all spread across the various parts of the plain, flocked to the news of Lloyd’s lecture. The crowd of centaurs was as thick as the clouds in the sky, and everyone came regardless of their age or gender. There were couples with kids, eldery who claimed to be as healthy as a horse, and foal centaurs who wished to become a champion of reckless racing in the future. Within a few days, the Stone and Wind village was packed with centaurs who came to listen to Lloyd’s lecture.

The following morning rolled around. At last, the lecture titled “What is Speeding?” started.

“Ehem, thank you all for gathering. My name is Lloyd Frontera.”

Lloyd greeted the group of over a thousand centaurs gathered at the meadow near the Stone and Wind village. He slightly shifted to show his back as he spoke with a booming voice charged with mana. His red speeding ticket was proudly stuck behind him. Soft exclamations of admiration spilled among the centaurs.

“It’s real... It’s really the red speeding ticket.”

“It’s glorious to see it with my own eyes.”

“Mother, I’ve never seen anything like that.”

“Make sure to get a good look, sweetie. Promise me you’ll grow up to become a great adult who earns hundreds of those tickets, got it?”

Whisper! Clamor! The awe-filled murmuring filled the area, and the gazes fixed on Lloyd were full of admiration. Lloyd remained silent for a second until the noise subsided.

When everyone seemed to have calmed down, he spoke again. “Yes, nice to meet you. I am the human who received a red speeding ticket. I am sure you have come here because you are curious about the secret behind my running ability. That is right! What do I mean by speeding? From now on, I would like to have a meaningful time with you by having an in-depth discussion about what speeding is. Shall we begin with a round of applause?”

Clap! Clap! Clap! Lloyd was natural on the stage with the centaurs. A smile of contentment appeared on his mouth.

“Yes, clapping makes you feel good, doesn’t it? That’s how important blood circulation is. Now, allow me to start the actual lecture. What is speeding? I am sure that this is a question all of you constantly ask yourself every day without fail. Am I correct?”

Nod! Everyone nodded. It was true. What was speeding? How could they gallop faster? What should they do to race faster than their competitors? Those concerns were on their brain every second of the day. It was something that stayed on their mind for the rest of their lives. Lloyd prepared his lecture being well aware of this fact. With a big, broad smile on his face, he resumed speaking.

“To tell you the conclusion first... Speeding is the most foolish thing you could ever do.”

Everyone’s eyes widened in surprise. Their eyes said, “What are you talking about?!” But Lloyd didn’t stop there and relentlessly continued his lecture.

“Running faster? Sure, it’s good. Refreshing. Exhilarating even. But look. Think about it. Galloping anywhere you please and bragging about your speed... Don’t you think it’s a bit immature and childish?”

“...”

“In the past few days,” Lloyd went on, ignoring their shocked silence. “I’ve seen how many of you behave during my stay here. A lot of you race at full speed, even inside the village. Very recklessly. You all thoughtlessly charge forward regardless of whether you are at a crossroad between stables, an alley between tents, or a play area for young foals. I did witness countless accidents, both big and small. There were also several times an accident almost happened.”

“...”

“Will that do?” Lloyd’s voice was now accusatory. “So what if you can run fast? Your raging speed brings nothing but trouble. It just hurts innocent centaurs and yourselves as well. Do you know what we call someone like that in the human world? A nuisance.”

No one said anything. But the silence was rather cold, and so were the gazes fixed on Lloyd. They were colder than Lloyd expected. A bitter smile appeared on his face as he recalled his days in South Korea.

Korea has more reckless drivers than you’d expect too.

There were quite a lot, actually. It was common for drivers to move forward without stopping at an intersection, even when the pedestrian light turned green. Some even squeezed through crossing pedestrians. On roads without traffic lights, it was common for cars to ignore pedestrians who were on the crosswalk first. Only a handful of cars stopped for people to pass by.

Not only that, a lot of drivers park in no parking zones or near the fire hydrants or pedestrians. It’s more uncommon for people to speed than to not. They only slow down when there are cameras around and hit the gas as soon as they’re cleared. I was guilty of that, too.

Before joining the military and his family went bankrupt, there was a time Lloyd drove his father’s car to Busan after getting his driver’s license. That was when he learned that the 60 mph speed limit on the highways was only for show around cameras. Everyone drove over 70, 80, 90 mph when there was nothing watching them. It was the same even inside cities.

The speed limit of 30 mph was ignored by everyone. But even then, that's on the mild side of things. Most people aren't truly reckless drivers and just go slightly above the speed limit. But some... Ha.

The thought alone prompted Lloyd to sigh. He occasionally encountered a reckless driver. There were some who risked their lives to tailgate him on the road at full speed. Others speedily tailed the car ahead to cross an intersection before the light turned red. There were drivers who even went on a transcontinental journey from one end of the road to the other by incessantly switching lanes. At times, there were people who also threw cigarette butts out their windows. In other instances, there were drivers who honked and turned on their high beams just because the car in the front was moving a little slow.

Those instances were blatant examples of reckless driving.

The problem was that these violations weren't rare. They happened quite often. This reality was shocking. Lloyd couldn't help but wonder what those drivers were thinking inside their car. And Lloyd held the same sentiments now.

The centaurs are similar. They just aren't aware of their recklessness because that's the norm for them. Reckless galloping is a part of their culture. They just can't accept the notion that different areas need to have different speed limits.

Their sole focus was galloping at an outrageous speed. Safety and whatnot were not even a consideration. Lloyd figured that he had to change that. And so, Lloyd started to openly provoke the centaurs.

"If one has common sense and reason and knows how to be considerate of those around them, one would know where it is appropriate to race and where it is now. No one deuces anywhere they please. The same goes for galloping. One must be able to distinguish where to run at full speed and where to restrain themselves. Do you know what we call those who are incapable of doing so?"

"..."

No one gave an answer. Amid the even more frigid silence, Lloyd spoke, his voice ringing clearer.

“Airheads.” Lloyd’s voice slightly turned up to emphasize the word. “That’s the word. Unfortunately, that description fits a lot of your behaviors. You recklessly ran even when there were children around. You galloped across intersections, being inconsiderate of others, and only regretted it once you collided with someone and fell to the ground. What is that? Certainly not the proper way to gallop.”

“Then how do you want us to gallop, two-legged smartass?”

At last, a voice of opposition erupted from the crowd. It belonged to a young centaur who stood out from the rest. He was about 1.2 times bigger than the rest, and his hooves were thick and robust. His muscles moved as if they had been sculpted by an artist. The white, silky fur that covered his whole body was a remarkable sight to behold. Even his face was good-looking.

“Yes,” Lloyd acknowledged him. “Your name is?”

“Komanchi. Three-time champion of this plain.” Komanchi’s voice sounded intimidating and confident.

“A champion? Are you the fastest centaur here?”

“Yes. In addition, I am the future head chief who will lead all the centaurs on this land one day.”

Komanchi then turned his back toward Lloyd. Five red speeding tickets were plastered on his back. He said, “I suppose that is enough of an introduction about me. Anyway, I would like to ask you as you seem to be on the high horse. How does the best galloper with intelligence and thoughtfulness run? I would like to pick your smarty brain on that.”

“I see. That’s a good question. The answer is simple. It is to only race inside designated areas without causing harm to others.” Lloyd held up his hands, palm facing up toward the sky.

“Are you saying that we must limit our right to freely gallop?” Komanchi demanded.

“That is not a right but an act of disturbance.”

“It’s our tradition!” Komanchi protested.

“And a bad one.”

Feeling ever more frustrated, Komanchi growled, “Can you prove that arrogant statement of yours?”

“How do you want me to prove that I am right and take responsibility for my statement?” Lloyd’s voice, on the other hand, was calm.

“Race with me!” Komanchi, all worked up now, thwacked his chest several times. And he bawled, almost declaring, “I don’t think you have any idea about us since you’re a human, but we don’t listen to slowpokes. So prove that you’re faster than us!”

“Hmm, but I already received a red speeding ticket though.” Lloyd pointed to his back.

“That was the work of your hamster, not yours!” Komanchi thrust his finger in the air at Lloyd. “I’ve heard from my cousin, the patrol commander. You did the race while riding a hamster! So I cannot accept that. It’s pathetic. Use your own legs and run with the wind to prove you are a fast runner!”

“You’re saying that you’ll acknowledge my words if I race with you alone and win. Am I correct?”

“That’s right!”

“Mister Komanchi. Are you challenging me now?”

“What else do you think I’m doing?!” screamed Komanchi as he thought to himself that there was simply zero chance for him to lose in the race against the scrawny two-legged slug. Smiling confidently, he was determined to humble this conceited human in front of everyone.

Lloyd, too, flashed a big smile.

That human fell right into my trap! Komanchi thought proudly to himself.

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Chapter 293: Don’t Look Down on a Human (1)

It was a universally accepted fact and truth that no human, regardless of their abilities or status as a sword master, could outrun centaurs, the natural speeders and supreme cavalries of the plain.

“Are you confident that you will win?”

“Yeah. Of course.” When Javier asked with a worried expression on his face, Lloyd nodded and replied in a nonchalant voice, “That’s why I accepted his challenge. You think I’d have done it otherwise?”

Lloyd stole a glance around the corner of the plain in a section of the Stone and Wind tribe. An impressive number of centaurs were gathered in the distance, murmuring among themselves as they prepared to watch the race that was spontaneously scheduled a moment ago.

Lest the others heard him, Lloyd lowered his voice. “You think I will lose?”

“I do.”

“Wow. You didn’t even think about your answer.”

“It is an obvious and unequivocally true prediction.”

“For me to lose this race?”

“Yes. You are going up against a centaur. Not just anyone at that, but the three-time champion of the Great Plain.” Javier spoke in an unwavering voice. The knight was convinced. “Master Lloyd, I understand that you are on the verge of becoming a high-level sword expert. That will enable you to sprint significantly faster than an ordinary person. And since you are equipped with three mana circles, there will be no human who can outrun you unless they are a sword master.”

“I like where you are going,” said Lloyd. “Continue.”

“Yes, and there’s a reason why I am telling you this. As far as I am concerned, I believe that the champion centaur is able to run faster than a sword master.”

“So I am bound to lose without question?”

“Indeed.”

“How about you?”

“As for myself,” Javier replied, “I am likely faster than this centaur.”

“Woah!” Lloyd remarked heartily. “You’re just bragging about yourself.”

“Is that how you see this conversation?” Javier frowned.

“Yup.”

Javier stared hard at Lloyd.

“What? What? What is it?” Lloyd opened his eyes wider.

“You will certainly lose. I suggest you tell them that you changed your mind.”

“Not happening.” Lloyd shook his head.

“Then do you have a plan?”

“Obviously. I have one. I told you that a while ago. You weren’t listening to me.”

“Well… What is it?”

“If you’re curious, just watch. Shh. He’s coming over here.”

Komanchi, the champion centaur, was approaching Lloyd. The muscles on the horse half of his body bulged as if to signal he was already prepared for

the race. Throwing a defiant glance at Lloyd, Komanchi asked, “How are you? Ready for our race?”

“You bet. I am ready.”

“Then I assume you’ve decided on where to set the finish line, the place where you will cry tears of defeat.”

“I did choose the place where I will throw my victory ceremony,” parried Lloyd.

“Where is the finish line?” Komanchi stared at Lloyd, his gaze burning more intensely. Actually, he didn’t like Lloyd from the get-go, ever since he stepped foot in this village.

Hmph! He didn’t earn the speeding ticket with his own legs!

Komanchi heard about the race from his patrol commander, his cousin, who said that Lloyd rode an extremely fast and giant hamster during his race. This pissed Komanchi off.

That’s not fair!

Real men ran with their own legs. That was the true meaning of racing. The only permissible one. Humans loved to talk about how fast they were while being carried on the back of something, but Komanchi didn’t have an iota of intent to acknowledge it as a form of racing. That was why he had come to the lecture and not because he was curious about the content of it. No, not at all.

I came to challenge him to a race!

Komanchi’s plan was to prove before everyone else that the red speeding ticket seen on the human was nothing but a pretentious lie. In particular, he felt a strong desire to humiliate this human. It was his duty as the champion, he believed. And it was also a fitting punishment for the shameful human race that was incapable of sprinting with their own legs.

“So tell me now where the finish line will be. The one challenged to a race has the right to decide where it will take place.”

“Hmm,” observed Lloyd. “I get to choose wherever I want?”

“Certainly. That is our tradition.”

Komanchi lifted his jaw insolently. Since he was the one who threw down the gauntlet, it was only right for Lloyd to choose the racing track. Still, Komanchi couldn’t be any less worried.

I am faster! That is the truth! Wherever he chooses, I will cross the finish line first!

Komanchi was absolutely certain. He couldn’t imagine anything close to defeat. Whatever the course was, wherever the finish line stood, none of them mattered to Komanchi. But a second later, when he finally learned of the finish line, he wasn’t sure if he heard it right.

“Very well,” Lloyd said, “The race will end at the front yard of the border guard commander’s manor, which sits at the southern border of this plain.”

“What...?”

“Let’s run to the front of the manor belonging to the commander who guards the northern border of the Magentano kingdom,” elaborated Lloyd patiently.

Seeing that Komanchi wasn’t saying anything, he added, “Did you not hear me?”

“No,” said Komanchi finally, “I, I did. But...”

“But what?”

“That’s at least 370 miles away from here!”

“I know. So?”

“You want to race all the way there?”

“Yeah.”

“Are you out of your mind?!” shrieked Komanchi.

“No. Is anything wrong?” asked Lloyd.

Komanchi almost yelled out, Of course, there’s something wrong! This is terribly and immensely wrong!

All I wanted was a race. Why is this nut job challenging me to journey across the entire land?

For some reason, Komanchi felt cheated and wanted to protest. But all his dumbstruck mouth could utter was a broken stutter.

Lloyd, flashing a cunning smile on his face, asked, “Do you feel cheated?”

Of course, he did! But Komanchi wasn’t spared the chance to shout his thoughts as Lloyd interrupted him.

“Don’t be so wrapped up in it. Remember. You were the one who told me to decide on the finish line.”

Komanchi gaped silently.

“Besides,” Lloyd went on, “You told me that I have the right to decide since I was the one who was challenged.”

“Yes, that’s right, but—”

“All I am doing is dutifully obeying the beautiful and sacred tradition of the centaurs.”

Komanchi had no comebacks. But he was overcome with a strong desire to throw a hind-leg kick at Lloyd’s smug face. Even though he wanted to protest, Komanchi couldn’t. After all, what the human said was right.

It’s true. He’s following our tradition.

The procedure for a race went like this: The one who took up the gauntlet was given the right to determine the location of the race track and the finish line. The one who threw down the gauntlet had no right to refuse. That was their tradition and sacred rule. These customs and mannerisms dictated the challenger to acquiesce to the terms of a race without complaint.

Come to think of it, he did the same thing when he went up against my cousin.

Just then, Komanchi recalled what his cousin had told him about the race against that human, who challenged him to a race. His cousin, accepting the game, suggested racing to a rock far away from them and gave Lloyd a red speeding ticket after losing.

I was deceived... Who on earth is this man?

Feeling terrified and scared, Komanchi stared at Lloyd, who was still beaming with a happy smile.

It’s as if a thousand serpents live inside his head!

That was it. This human was a schemer with thousands of trickery and chicaneries up his sleeves, only that he never showed it. What was more, he was the type who made sure to play only within the rules!

Tsk... What a deceitful man.

Grit! Komanchi clenched his teeth, realizing he had been completely fooled. But he didn’t allow himself to be flustered. There was something that remained unchanged despite all of the man’s cheeky tactics.

The result of this race will be the same! The ending where I trot out victorious!

This human could resort to using cunning tricks. But he was still hundreds of times faster. He had the upper hand. Thinking so, Komanchi was able to restore his composure.

Finally regaining composure, Komanchi lifted his chin high. “Good. I will accept your decision.”

“Of course, you do,” commented Lloyd. “Okay, so the finish line will be at the front yard of the guard commander’s manor, which sits at the southern border of the plain.”

“...”

Komanchi shook his head roughly, fighting the desire to hurl out an insult. Then he shot a burning glare at Lloyd. “You cannot ride anything until you reach the finish line. And, of course, there are no breaks allowed. We are gallopers and don’t rest until we cross the finish line. So, you are expected to do the same.”

“I expect nothing less,” said Lloyd.

“Moreover, the news of this race will spread across the entire plain. The entire plain will see us race as we pass by each of the villages. So, mark my words.” Komanchi paused before giving a grave warning. “No cheating will be permitted. Hundreds, no, thousands of centaurs will have their eyes on us!”

“Oh, sure. I am aware of that.”

“Then, let us begin.”

“Be my guest.” Lloyd shrugged and stood at the starting line. And he waited for the go sign. And at last...

“Race!”

Boooom! As soon as the go signal was made, Komanchi flung his body forward with force so mighty that he shook the ground. His giant muscles fiercely bulged as his body shot forward.

Gallop! Thwack! Komanchi dashed at lightning speed as he produced a large sandstorm. The ground shook each time his hooves touched the

ground. Within five seconds, he was going over 62 mph, a speed befitting his status as a three-time champion of the plain. Lloyd, however...

“Hmph! Hmph! Hmph! Hmph!”

His pace was no different than normal and too relaxed. The ground didn’t shake, or he didn’t charge like a storm. His start was more relaxed and carefree than the race against the patrol commander. The onlooking centaurs frowned as they looked at him and thought...

What’s this pathetic takeoff?

Is that what he considers running?

Is he the same guy who received the red speeding ticket?

Even a newborn foal would be faster than him!

They were gutted. His running was horrendous. The slow stretch of his legs was surely unbecoming of a red-ticketed speedster. The observing centaurs’ eyes held a glint of disappointment.

It looks like the race is over already.

It’s going to be years before he gets to the finish line.

Tsk, tsk, tsk. Poor Komanchi. He has to race all the way to the border of the human kingdom against this pathetic slowpoke. What a drudgery.

That two-legged man isn’t worth racing. He’s helpless.

Everyone shook their heads as they eyed Lloyd with pity. Except for one spectator. Javier.

Fake Master Lloyd. Did you really have to do this to win?

Javier was running as well but keeping a safe distance from Lloyd. He rooted for Lloyd as he jogged, thinking that Lloyd would end up as the

winner of this race and the mocking centaurs would be shell-shocked in a few days from now.

Though they'll never be able to foresee it by the looks of the race.

Javier had a hunch and became certain of it. Just like that, he wordlessly followed Lloyd. On the other hand, a large number of centaurs who watched the race at the starting line turned back with the conviction that Komanchi would reach the finish line first as the human was running terribly slow. There was no doubt about it, they believed. Not even bothering to follow the two, everyone gave no more attention to the race and decided to just hear the story from Komanchi once he came back as the winner. Everyone clicked their tongues and scoffed at themselves for being so foolish to have once looked up to the human just because he had a red speeding ticket.

As such, it was beyond their wildest dreams when something happened four days later, something shocking enough to cause the centaurs to tap their foreheads with their hooves.

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Chapter 294: Don’t Look Down on a Human (2)

Running was an act that every creature relied on to quickly arrive at their desired location. The world teemed with creatures faster than humans, with the exception of some animals such as pandas or sloths. It was rather a difficult job to find those that were slower than humans. And yet, despite their distinctive lack of speed, they were exceptional when it came to running a long distance for a long period of time. Yes, humans were evolved for long-distance running.

“Hmph! Hoo, hoo! Hmph! Hmph! Hoo!”

Lloyd ran southward. He ran endlessly for several hours since he left the starting line. His running speed was extremely fast compared to an average human but shamefully slow compared to centaurs. He was a snail compared to Komanchi, his competitor. But Lloyd didn’t stop. He kept moving his two legs, slow and steady, without giving up. He was certain that this was the surefire way to win.

Yes, this is the greatness of mankind!

Lloyd thought as he adjusted his pace.

This is the advantage humans have. We have the ability to run for a long time. There is no other creature that even comes close to this skill of ours.

It was really the case. With short-distance running, humans fell behind almost all of the other creatures since they only had two legs and were in an upright position that received a lot of wind resistance. Their running speed was clearly limited by their physical characteristics. But long-distance running was a whole different story.

It’s because of our sweat!

Lloyd wiped the sweat off his face. The cool breeze of the highland cooled the drops of sweat on him. In return, this process cooled the heat

accumulated in his body from running. His body temperature didn’t rise beyond a certain point, so Lloyd was able to run without stopping.

Additionally, humans are great at conserving their strength!

Having only two legs for propulsion meant less energy consumption. There were only a few muscles used for running, so this allowed for efficient energy management.

“Hmph! Hoo, hoo! Hmph! Hmph! Hoo!”

Thankfully, Lloyd was able to keep running without any breaks, much like some indigenous people or ancient humans such as the homo erectus species who ran hundreds of miles to hunt deer or wild boars. Just like that, Lloyd doggedly worked his two legs to keep charging forward, putting every bodily human feature to best use. Lloyd’s past experiences also became a source of help.

Hoo! Hoo! I am! Actually! Good at long-distance running!

Lloyd recalled the days when he received special swordsmanship training from Javier. The first exercise they did was running. On top of that, physical labor was something he was acutely familiar with as he had to frequent construction sites to make ends meet. There was even an instance when he climbed four flights of stairs carrying bricks on his back.

Compared to that, this is a walk in the park! Hoo! Hoo! A stroll!

Not only that, he had useful skills with him.

Ziiing! The three-stranded mana circle rotated violently with the beating of his heart. During his run, he absorbed a small volume of mana hanging in the air and rotated as well as amplified it. The amplified mana was then shoved into his manaheart, which then worked to distribute top-tier mana back to his muscles.

The mana distribution vitalized his whole body like he drank a refreshing cup of cold water provided by a farmer in the Alps. There were many

elements that allowed Lloyd to become a tireless running machine, including his long-distance running abilities as a human, rich experience with physical labor, running skills taught by Javier, and a combination of mana circle and manaheart. Though he wasn't extraordinarily fast, he was an unstoppable, zealous turtle of the Great Plain. As for Komanchi, who was far ahead of Lloyd, he was doing good. At least, that was true in the beginning.

"Ha! Haaa!"

Gallop! Gallop! Gallop! A dust storm exploded under his hooves, and he charged forward like an enraged tornado. He was a wild horse, both literally and figuratively. His aggressive galloping directly contrasted Lloyd's leisurely jog.

Of course! A human can't be faster than me!

From the moment his hooves left the starting line, after three trots, Komanchi distanced himself from his pathetic human competitor. The distance between them only grew afterward. Within five gallops, the human was nothing but a bean-sized figure. At seven, he was a tiny point. At 20, he was invisible. A speck of dust. As Lloyd vanished in his vision, the happier he became.

This is what we call a race! Hmph!

It was refreshing. The touch of the wind. The lively sensation surged in him as he charged across the plain. And the gutted look on his fading opponent.

Komanchi believed he had trounced his opponent. At least on the first day. But only on the first day.

"Ha! Whew! Whew! Haa!"

Gallop! Gallop! One day later, Komanchi's galloping speed slowed down visibly. No, to be technically correct, his slowing pace was noticeable after one hour into the race. There wasn't any complicated reason behind this. The change occurred because Komanchi was hot and tired.

This is... not as easy as I thought! Haah! Whew!

Komanchi clenched his teeth as his whole body began to sweat profusely. His body felt excessively hot like it was set on fire. He feared he'd faint if he continued on as he was. Reluctantly, Komanchi slowed down. That made him feel better.

It's okay. I've already created a large distance between me and that slowpoke.

Komanchi wasn't worried. He thought he had a good amount of time to spare. He had sprinted fast enough at the beginning of the race and covered a large distance. And besides, that human was eerily slow. It would be impossible for Lloyd to catch up with him.

There's no way I'll lose. Never!

Komanchi was confident and convinced. Another day passed.

"Ugh...! Haah! Hoo! Hoo! Argh!"

By this time, Komanchi was walking now. He couldn't even dream of galloping in this state, and even cantering was too much of a struggle.

I'm... drained!

It was too hot. He was scared that his knees would buckle down. His whole body was drained of energy. And as a last-ditch effort, he decided to walk, never stopping and still feeling relieved that he was remaining in the lead. He kept walking southward. The following day...

"Cough! Cough! Achoo! A... choo! Ugh!"

By this time, Komanchi was practically dragging his hooves. There was no more strength left in him. He was seconds before passing out, and just walking was becoming impossible. The blue sky looked yellow in his vision, and he foamed at the mouth. He tried to move, but his knees disobeyed him, as did his ankles. But he showed burning determination, befitting his title as the champion centaur.

I cannot stop now. The finish line must be near. I... am fast! I cannot collapse like this!

Komanchi widened his eyes and clenched his fists. Burning resolution. Now, his mental fortitude was the only fuel that moved his exhausted body. Komanchi dragged his whole body, going at 0.3 mph. Even still, he was rest assured.

Still, I will win! Of course! If I'm this tired right now, then it's obvious how much worse it has to be for that slowpoke! I bet he's already lying flat on the ground completely unconscious!

Komanchi had no doubt about it. There was no other possibility. He believed that the finish line would emerge soon. Afterward, all there was left for him to do after passing the southern border was to meet the human guards and ask them to direct him to their commander's front yard. Komanchi persisted and crawled forward. But the reality was harsher than he hoped it to be.

"Hmph! Hoo, hoo! Hmph! Hmph! Hoo!"

Just then, Komanchi perked up his ears. He suddenly started to pick up regular breathing from behind. And it was nearing.

What's that?

At first, he thought he was hearing things out of sheer exhaustion as he was seconds away from passing out. But it turned out that his ears were right.

"Hmph! Hoo, hoo! Hmph! Hmph! Hoo!"

"Eh...?" His dazed vision caught something past him. The figure was covered in sweat and running very slowly. Komanchi spotted the red speeding ticket on the man's back. It was Lloyd Frontera, his human competitor!

Impossible!

Could it be that he was hallucinating? Or was he dreaming now? Komanchi thought at first. But that wasn't the case. No matter how hard he rubbed his eyes, shook his head, or even stood on his hind legs, the back in front of him belonged to his human competitor.

W-what? What's going on?!

A sense of panic overcame Komanchi. He hurriedly flexed his leg muscles and encouraged himself to run. He was the champion. He could do it. But it was useless.

Drag... Five inches. That was the distance his panic-stricken effort took him.

No. This is a lie. Ugh...

Komanchi tried to exert some more effort. But only in vain. He was completely drained. Eventually, he fell. He couldn't move anymore. And he panted on the ground as the vision around him started to grow dark. Sometime later...

"Goodness. Why are you sleeping here? You'll get sick," uttered Lloyd. He slapped Komanchi's cheek a few times.

Komanchi was awakened by a sharp and sudden sensation on his skin. His eyes flew open.

"It's salt water. Drink this up first and get your energy back."

Komanchi noticed the cup a hand was holding out and the water swaying in it. He soon saw who it was. "Lloyd Frontera?"

"You recognize me," said Lloyd, "I guess you aren't in a critical state. What a relief."

Komanchi stared, dazed.

"Don't stare at me like that. Here. Drink this first."

Komanchi accepted the glass in a daze and drained the cup. The liquid was salty and cool. It was only then that his head started to ache.

“Ack... What... happened?” Komanchi couldn’t make out what was happening. Why am I on the ground when I’m supposed to be racing? And why is he giving me a cup of water? And what is that gaze and expression on his face? Everything was a mystery to Komanchi. But the answer he received from the human was simple.

“What do you mean what happened? The race is over.”

“What?” Komanchi’s voice broke.

“It’s over. The race.”

“...”

“I’m telling you.”

“Th-Then who won-”

“Me. Duh,” interrupted Lloyd.

“...”

“Don’t believe me?”

“Like I could!” reflexively bawled Komanchi at him. “You saw how the race started! How I was wretchedly ahead of you! And it was like that throughout the entire competition!”

“Except that it was me who passed the finish line first,” pointed out Lloyd with a calm expression on his face.

Komanchi felt dizzy.

“If you want proof of it, then take a look at the cup you’re holding.”

Not understanding what Lloyd meant, Komanchi hesitantly studied the glass in his hand. And there, he found an inscription.

[Congratulations on becoming the guard commander for the northern border.]

“Wh-what is this?” Komanchi said in dismay.

The corners of Lloyd’s lips rose as high at Komanchi’s dismay. “I’m glad that you can read the human alphabet. It’s a gift I found at the commander’s desk inside his manor.”

“...”

“No, actually, I borrowed it from the guard commander to prove it to you. You may not know this, but I’m a meritorious retainer of the House of Magentano. When I asked him politely, he even asked if I needed anything more.”

Komanchi didn’t respond to Lloyd. “So I brought a bundle of proof for you. Here’s his rank insignia. Status certificate. Here’s his toothbrush. And here’s a ceremonial sword and family flag from the queen herself. And yes, allow me to introduce the woman over here to you. She’s the commander’s wife.”

“...”

Komanchi dazedly stared at an elegant human woman bowing at him. That was when it became clear to him.

I lost.

This was enough proof. He lost the race. There came from the corner of his brain a screaming voice that said the human had cheated. But Komanchi shook his head and banished the thought.

Deception? No. That’s impossible. My fellow centaurs across the entire plain were watching our race. They saw how we ran. There was no way for him to cheat. Plus, the human was ahead of me before I passed out...

That was when it came to him. Komanchi remembered how that man trudged ahead of him before he passed out. The man’s pace wasn’t fast, and his legs shook from exhaustion. But they didn’t stop moving. It looked like they’d never stopped.

It was real.

Komanchi, being a runner for his whole life, could tell whether one had run faithfully without cheating. And so, Komanchi accepted his defeat.

“I see. I... lost.”

The moment Komanchi accepted his defeat, a new title message popped in front of Lloyd.

Ding dong.

[With tenacity, persistence, and endurance that even turtles would be impressed by, you have won the race against the champion among centaurs.]

[Komanchi, the champion of Klamath, is deeply moved by your tenacity.]

[The story of this impressive race will spread to all corners of the plain through the mouths of Komanchi and its spectators.]

[Centaurs have bestowed you with a new title.]

[A new title <Don’t Look Down on a Human Ever Again> has been created.]

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Chapter 295: Don’t Look Down on a Human (3)

Ding dong.

[The centaurs have bestowed you with a new title.]

[A new title <Don’t Look Down on a Human Ever Again> has been created.]

Damn.

The message appeared in front of Lloyd’s eyes with a pleasant ding. This was the kind of moment he found most rewarding. It made him feel like he achieved something. Feeling content, he cast his gaze on the compliment’s description.

[Don’t Look Down on a Human Ever Again]

[Title Level: Regional Folktale]

Trot. Trot. There once was a man. He ran in the morning. In the afternoon. In the evening. With his only two legs, he waddled and created a distasteful sight. And he was slow, so slow that even a foal would yawn. But he was faster than four-legged creatures. He ran across the vast plain and reached the territory of the humans. He proved that the one who arrives at the finish line first is faster than the one who runs fast. So, what do you have to do if you wish to run like him? How about you start running southward? Just 372 miles.

[Compliment Effect: With your marvelous show of tenacity and endurance, you have opened a new era of long-distance running to the centaurs. The centaur champion and many others who watched the race genuinely accepted your long-distance running method. Owing to it, your reputation will spread to every corner of the vast plain, and the new running method - running a long distance while saving energy - will be a trend among the young centaurs. Moreover, you have acquired a new passive effect <Fuel

Efficiency> that reduces the energy consumption by half in situations where your heartbeat goes over 140 every minute.]

[Title Region: The Great Plain of Klamath. Any plain ground with a land mass of over 1,000m^2]

[Active Period of Title: 160 Years.]

[A title's powers can be activated for 24 hours in the region for which the compliment was given. Moreover, time and region can expand or shrink depending on your actions.]

[Monthly CP Earned from the Title: 2]

[Current CP: 1,477]

Hahaha.

Lloyd let out a forced laugh after reading through the compliment effect. He couldn't help it. The effect was more than he expected.

This is pretty awesome. I'll be consuming only half of my energy if my heart beats above 140 times a minute when I'm on plain ground with a land mass of over 1,000m^2.

At first glance, the required conditions for activation could seem difficult to meet. However, they were fairly simple demands upon further thought.

Of course. A simple exercise can easily bring your heart rate to 140 beats per minute. Moreover, it's quite common for a plain to possess this kind of land mass.

As such, those conditions weren't exactly hard to meet. They were actually pretty generous. Once those conditions were satisfied, Lloyd would only consume half of the energy he normally did.

This is sweet.

The skill would be useful for any risky or urgent situations. Concluding with that thought, Lloyd looked up at Komanchi, who was lying on the ground in utter exhaustion.

“Please wait here while I go and return the items I borrowed.”

It was time to return everything Lloyd borrowed to prove his victory: The guard commander’s mug cup, rank insignia, certificate, toothbrush, ceremonial sword, family flag, and wife. He summoned Ggoming, fed the red sunflower seed to him, and returned the commander’s things to his wife.

Afterward, he came back to Komanchi and helped him get to his feet and on Ggoming’s back. And he urged Javier, who dutifully joined him throughout the race from behind him, to come on board. The two humans and one centaur were barely able to fit on top of Ggoming’s back. After they returned to the Stone and Wind village, Lloyd announced his victory to everyone.

“After a fierce race, I crossed the finish line first,” announced Lloyd to everyone. “Right?”

“Yes, I accept my defeat. Lloyd won this race,” seconded Komanchi.

Everyone’s eyes widened at the announcement. They all wore a look of disbelief, but Lloyd didn’t care about their dismay. He simply proceeded to claim his reward for victory.

“So, may I please have your attention!”

Lloyd’s commanding voice silenced the murmuring voices of the centaurs, and everyone put all their focus on him.

“Anyway,” Lloyd declared, “The race is over. Yes. Mister Komanchi reigned as the champion of this plain for three years until I emerged and proved to be faster than him.”

The crowd was filled with silence. Amidst it, someone dryly swallowed. Everyone wondered in nervous anticipation what the human had to say.

Lloyd continued, “Yes, I am faster than Mister Komanchi. That means that I am faster than all of you here and any centaur in this world. Now, do you remember what the ex-champion said right before the race began?”

Lloyd smiled meaningfully. At last, everyone’s bad feeling was actualized. “Centaurs never listen to the words of a slowpoke. Right?”

The crowd remained deathly silent.

“Am I correct?”

Still, no one spoke.

“Hmm?” mused Lloyd as he narrowed his eyes. “Are you all sleeping?”

Despite Lloyd’s questions, they all clamped their mouths shut.

“Well, since you’re not answering me, I’ll answer my question then. Mister Komanchi did say those words without a doubt. With that in mind, it is also true that I am faster than everyone here. In conclusion, from now on, you all must obey my orders.”

Ba-dump. Everyone’s heart sank. Lloyd, not giving any mind to their reaction, continued to speak.

“As such, I will enact a few rules. The rules that I tell you now do not apply only to the Stone and Wind tribe. It applies to every centaur who inhabits the Klamath Plain.” Lloyd’s gaze raked over everyone at the lot. His eloquent smile deepened. At last, he made his declaration, and it shocked everyone.

“Rule number one. No more sprinting in the village.”

“What?!”

“Oh, what kind of rule is that?!”

Young centaurs protested aloud as soon they heard Lloyd. But once again, he completely took no notice of them. Even if they did a tumbling or

headspin in surprise, they were invisible to the man.

“Rule number two.” Lloyd continued nonchalantly. “From now on, courtship races will only take place in the coliseum, which will be constructed soon.”

This time, no one jumped. But not because they accepted Lloyd’s announcement. They simply understood from Lloyd’s shameless face and adamant voice that there was no room for negotiation. Lloyd wasn’t having a discussion with them. He was making an announcement. This was a notice not a debate. His last words confirmed their thoughts.

“Okay, I will ask you then. Is there anyone who is against my rules?”

No one voiced any objection.

“I knew there wouldn’t be. After all, you all are slower than me.

No one responded once again.

“If you feel wronged, then you can always challenge me and prove that you’re a faster runner.”

Still, no one spoke. This time again, they realized that challenging the man would be useless. The result would be the same as the previous race. The reason was simple.

He’s going to use his right as the challenged individual and choose the most advantageous finish line for himself! It’ll be around 300 miles from here then too!

Everyone shuddered. There could be no other human who was as cunning, conniving, and deceiving enough as him to put their champion centaur in such a terrible state.

On second thought, are all humans like him?

It would be a large problem if that was true. The possibility was horrifying. Everyone shuddered at the thought. Even though they found the whole

situation unfair and shudderingly unacceptable, they couldn’t oppose him. They couldn’t think of a way to outrun him. Eventually, everyone reluctantly nodded.

As soon as he convinced everyone, Lloyd zoomed back to the head chief’s stable and announced, “I have persuaded them to follow my rules.”

“You persuaded them?” Chief Cherokan frowned.

“Yes.”

“Really?”

“Certainly,” said Lloyd with a smug.

“Hmm, you see, I also have eyes and ears of my own.”

“Then you should’ve seen and heard it clearly.”

“Tsk... Who knew you would resort to such a sly scheme,” the chief scratched his neck.

“Anyway,” Lloyd said as he ignored the remark, “Everyone agreed to comply with my safety regulations, taking one burden off your shoulders with it, Chief. We’re not just talking about the centaurs in the Wind and Stone tribe but everyone across this plain.”

“Well, I will give you that. That was truly amazing.” Head Chief Cherokan expressed his genuine admiration. The emotion was so intense that he smiled wryly. “I wondered what your plan would be that made you possess so much confidence. However, it never crossed my mind that you would suggest racing across such a stupidly long distance and end up as the winner.”

“Is that so, Chief?”

“Yes, if I’m being honest. Hence, my surprise. Since you kept your promise, it’s time for me to keep mine.”

“Thank you, Chief. Please sign here.”

Flap! Lloyd immediately fished a document out of his embrace at Cherokan’s words.

Cherokan knit his eyebrows. “What is this?”

“It is a construction contract.”

“Construction... contract?”

“Yes.” Lloyd nodded. Licking his lips he said, “Do you remember how we signed the conditional agreement a few days ago? About how you would accept my suggestion and allow the coliseum construction to begin if I persuade your centaurs’?”

“Y-Yes, I did.”

“This contract clarifies all of our contract terms, so to speak.”

“Are you talking about the paper you’re holding out to me?”

“Yes,” replied Lloyd, “Time to keep your promise.”

For a second, Cherokan wondered if all humans were like the one in front of him. Nonetheless, he stamped the new contract, but not without a slight feeling that he had been bewitched. The contract promised that Head Chief Cherokan would teach Lloyd where Taupo was if the latter built a coliseum for them.

“Very well,” Lloyd said as he smiled as bright as his face. “You have made a wise choice.”

“Are you going to start the construction now?”

“Yes, Chief. I should. And as mentioned in the contract, you must assist by providing as much labor and construction materials as possible.”

“I see. I ask that you do a good job with the coliseum or whatever if it’s going to be built.”

“You’ve got nothing to worry about,” assured Lloyd before leaving the stable. It was only then that he was able to breathe out loud.

“Haah...”

He did it. He got the contract for the coliseum project. But he didn’t have any time to relax or recharge.

Recharge, my ass! Time to work!

Lloyd planned to enjoy life. And that could only happen if he had a solid foundation for it, which was the Frontera County for him. The first thing was to stop the restoration of destiny from happening.

As such, there was no time to relax. Lloyd decided that he had to bust his tail until the relaxed life of abundance he always yearned for would actualize. He then immediately proceeded to survey the area. Thankfully, the open land offered a lot of space for him to put up the coliseum. And since it barely rained in the plain, he didn’t have to concern himself with building drains as well.

It was such a great location for construction that he couldn’t help but repeat to himself, “I wish I could construct in a place like this every day!” Anyway, Lloyd didn’t intend to build a coliseum as big as the one in Rome.

It’s not necessary to do that. I just have to create a track where they can sprint without worry. A space that’s separated from their everyday life.

That was the crux of this project. As such, the coliseum he planned to build wouldn’t look like the ones in ancient Rome. Instead, it would look very similar to race car tracks or horse tracks.

So, I have to set aside a vast amount of land for this project. The track needs to be well-built. And this area will be where the audience can spectate...

Apart from those things, Lloyd worked on several other sections of the coliseum, like the waiting and rest areas, as well as the areas for emergency treatment. He ran thousands of different scenarios that could happen during a race and designed the facility accordingly.

The track is the most crucial structure for a racing competition. It's directly related to everyone's safety. But it can't be hard to maintain and should be sturdy enough to be free from damage in the long run.

Lloyd designed the coliseum with a fine-tooth comb and ran countless tests, skipping sleep and focusing on the project. Ten, fifteen days passed. Around the time the bags under his eyes couldn't get any larger, he completed the design for the coliseum.

The next step is to freeze time.

Finally, the time had come. The time had come to use the Time Freeze skill to save the time that would be used for construction.

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Chapter 296: The Impact of the Coliseum (1)

Everyone had at least one secret. It could be an unspeakable past or an embarrassing mistake. Whatever it was, disclosing a secret was no easy task. And it was even more troublesome if someone's secret was possessing a ridiculous power such as the ability to stop time.

Lloyd, however, mustered courage by pretending as though the thought suddenly popped into his head in the middle of breakfast. He stared intensely at Javier while slurping down his soup. Javier felt the gaze, letting go of his spoon.

“Do you have something to say?” asked Javier as he wiped his mouth with a napkin.

“I do,” replied Lloyd.

“Do you want me to pass you the black pepper?”

“No, nothing like that.” Lloyd shook his head.

“Or the salt?”

“I don’t need salt. Actually…” Lloyd sighed. His voice sounded heavy. “I can stop time.”

Instead of giving any response, Javier decided to say nothing.

“I’m serious,” Lloyd insisted.

Javier studied Lloyd’s face first. “Hmm... You are perfectly awake.”

“I’m telling you!” Lloyd was persistent.

“You are not sleep-talking.”

“This isn’t a joke.”

“The soup is not poisoned either.” Javier looked at his soup.

“I mean it.”

“Your eyes are normal.”

“Hey...”

“All right.”

“What?” Lloyd stopped.

The corners of Javier’s lips rose upward. “I said, all right. I understand that you can stop time.”

“All right with what?”

“What you told me,” Javier explained in a casual voice, “Stopping time.”

“So you believe me?”

“Yes, Young Master.”

Javier’s nonchalant, carefree attitude flustered Lloyd. “H-how? I-I can stop time. Is that easily believable to you?”

“I have no choice but to believe you.”

“Why?”

“There is no other way.” Javier’s gaze fixed on Lloyd. It was serious and grave. “Do you remember, Young Master? The first time you told me you would construct an ondol.”

Lloyd nodded.

“That was when I first started to think you’d lost your mind.”

“Hmm...” Lloyd choked and coughed.

“But strangely,” Javier articulated, “Your actions and plans that I regarded as deranged in the past turned out to benefit the family when they were put into action.” Javier knitted his brows as if he were recollecting an event. “It was the case for the ondol, the waterway, and the mine. Well, there is no need for me to list them all. Everything you have done so far has led to the same result.”

Lloyd squinted his eyes at Javier. “Tsk. And each time, you thought I had gone mad?”

“Yes.” Javier’s response came right away.

“And the more deranged you thought I was, the more right I was about everything?” asked Lloyd, slightly in disbelief.

“Yes.”

“So you still think I am a madman.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

“But thanks to that, you can trust me now?”

“Yes.”

“My, I can’t be more thankful.” Lloyd exhaled, slightly dumbstruck by this revelation.

“You are welcome,” replied Javier with an elegant smile on his face. “You were exactly like this a while ago. With your disheveled morning hair, which looks like a bird’s nest, by the way, you looked straight into my eyes and told me that you could stop time.”

“And I looked like a man who had lost his mind.” Lloyd folded his arms.

“You still do, in fact,” Javier confessed, “It is subtle, but you still do.”

“Oh, yeah?”

“Yes, Young Master. I suppose you got the power after absorbing the Heart of Winter?”

“Uh-huh.” This conversation relieved Lloyd. It looked like Javier was really buying his words. To put an end to the matter, Lloyd quickly added, “How should I say this? I just had a feeling about it ever since I absorbed the Heart of Winter.”

“You mean the ability to stop time?”

“Yeah,” confirmed Lloyd. “All thanks to the Heart of Winter.”

“Have you tried it yet?”

“No.” Lloyd shook his head. “Technically speaking, I can designate a certain area where time will continue flowing.”

“I see.” Javier understood what Lloyd’s plan was. “And you plan on using that power for this construction, is that right?”

“Yes, yes. That’s exactly my point.” Lloyd felt a rush of relief once again. He was scared that Javier might think of him weirdly.

Well, this is a relief. Surely, our trip to Hell really made us closer.

Come to think of it, Lloyd and Javier had been through all kinds of hardships together across the entire world, whether that was in the mountains, up in the sky, under the water, or down in Hell.

Our time together must have made him trust me more than before.

A sense of satisfaction rushed through Lloyd. Their days together and the hardships they had overcome must have contributed to Javier’s trust in him. Despite how Javier grumbled and called Lloyd a madman without hesitation, the knight was the only confidante he could rely on.

Obviously! There’s so much I invested in him! I helped him master the Asrahan Core Technique much earlier than in the original storyline. I’ve taught him how to use the mana blast, helped him sleep, clothed him, and

kept him fed! And by helping him sleep, I mean I sang him lullabies to lovingly put him to bed.

Thanks to all his efforts, Javier was now a grandmaster. The difference in his skill level between the original storyline and the current one was as vast as the distance between the sky and land.

And all the credit belongs to me.

Lloyd blew through his nose as he nodded and wondered if this was what a parent felt like watching their child pass the college entrance exam after diligently taking care of them while they studied. Anyway, now that Lloyd had earned Javier's trust, he cranked into action to freeze time.

To avoid creating panicked commotion among the centaurs, Lloyd first visited Cherokan and explained that he would freeze time before kickstarting the construction.

But his confident explanation was met with a subtle gaze that said, "Are you unwell?"

Lloyd simply smiled at the chief. Chief Cherokan clicked his tongue and explained everything to the centaurs without giving him much of a reply.

Two days later, Lloyd stood at the center of the plain with hundreds of centaurs watching him. Then he opened the optional skill window for his manaheart.

Ding dong.

[Skill Option ⑤: Time Freeze - You can freeze time of this world by borrowing the power of the Heart of Winter in your manaheart.]

[Required RP to use the skill: 3,000]

[Current RP: 4,655]

[Would you like to use the Skill Option ⑤: Time Freeze?]

[YES / NO]

Of course, it's a YES.

Lloyd nodded, and there was an immediate reaction.

[Skill Option ⑤: Time Freeze has been activated.]

[You have spent 3,000 RP.]

[Current RP: 1,655]

[From now on, with the power of the Heart of Winter, you can freeze one year's worth of time in this world. In addition, you can designate a no-freeze zone where time continues to flow as normal.]

[The range of the no-freeze zone is determined by the total amount of mana you possess.]

[Current Range: 250km^2]

[Please assign the range of the no-freeze zone.]

Lloyd was relieved that the range was wide enough. He provided the response he had already prepared in advance before activating the skill.

The largest range possible! Ack!!!

Crackle...! Abruptly, a large volume of mana started to slip out from his manaheart. It was as if Lloyd digested seven servings of grilled pork in ten seconds, emptying his stomach in the process. Soon, the mana turned into frigid air and jetted from him toward the sky in a straight line, which spread across the sky until it formed a dome shape. It looked like an umbrella, a giant bubble, or an upside-down bowl of rice. It covered the designated area of land by Lloyd and froze it at a quick speed. Eventually, a wall was created.

Ding dong.

[Time has been frozen.]

[The no-freeze zone cannot be altered until the optional skill is canceled.]

[The option will be deactivated in the event the user steps out of the no-freeze zone.]

[Any being within the range of the no-freeze zone will not age for a year.]

The message pleasantly filled Lloyd's vision. He let out the breath he'd been holding.

Whoa. It worked.

A pang of dizziness crept on him, along with a sensation of coldness. Lloyd grabbed his knees, and his arms and legs began to tremble. It felt like all his strength was leaving his body from head to toe. However, he was filled with a sense of overwhelming satisfaction at the same time.

It worked properly. The whole world has frozen except for this area.

Lloyd could feel that it worked because the Heart of Winter was in his heart. The Time Freeze was a success. Even so, Lloyd didn't sit back and solely rely on his senses.

I should confirm with my own eyes.

Lloyd tensed his trembling legs. He walked forward with a brave face to check if his optional skill was working properly.

Of course. Even if I feel confident about something, it's better to confirm whatever it is with my own eyes. This principle applies the same to construction sites. If a supervisor haphazardly performs a site inspection because everything looks fine on paper, their actions are destined to cause a disaster.

Lloyd had witnessed such incidents quite a few times back in South Korea. The high-ups rarely appeared at construction sites, and on the days they did, they merely gave a perfunctory glance at the site as they were accompanied by a large group of followers. Lloyd rarely saw them learn how the construction was done, keenly examine the work that was done, or get their hands dirty to give a thorough inspection.

It's the same right now. The skill option? Good. Message? It's convenient. But if I half-ass the inspection by relying on them, I'll run into a serious problem that I'll regret causing in the future.

The longer he inspected and examined the site, the better it was. As such, Lloyd was expected to do more than read over a report or message. He would need to use his eyes, ears, and all of his other senses to double or triple-check that everything was in place. With that thought in his head, Lloyd walked several miles and stood in front of the ice barrier created by the Heart of Winter.

Ha... This looks exactly like an upside-down rice bowl made of ice. And it seems I'm trapped inside of it…

The dome-shaped wall of ice was thin, barely half an inch thick, and allowed for a moderate amount of sunlight to come in from the outside. Lloyd took a good look at the scenery beyond the wall. Everything was frozen in place. An eagle hung in the air with its wings spread wide open, and a rabbit was frozen on the ground in a leaping position, trying to escape the eagle. The clump of grass that was flying in the air from her kick was also at a standstill. Everything in his vision had stopped moving.

The sun and clouds weren't an exception. It was as if someone had pressed the pause button on this world. Could it be because of such outrageous scenery in front of them? The centaurs who followed Lloyd murmured to themselves in dismay, chattering that the human's bravado turned out to be justified. The entire world froze aside from them. They nervously tapped their hooves against the ground as they wondered what would happen to them. This made Lloyd smile bitterly.

Tsk. It's too early for them to get nervous.

Lloyd had merely used his Time Freeze skill. There were more shocking events that would happen from then on.

That's obvious. I need big and strong laborers to start the construction off strong.

Therefore, Lloyd summoned the largest laborer he had put on stand-by the other day. Since the two were connected by soul, all Lloyd had to do was tell them inwardly to come over. With that, the laborer would soon arrive. A little later, the centaurs were shocked once again. This time, their surprise came along with the marvelous sound of clacking bones from somewhere in the distance. *Clack! Crack! Clack! Crack*

The ground shook, and a thick cloud of dust was produced as a giant bone, Draggy, came galloping. Draggy had received the order to put on a friendly appearance for the centaurs before time had frozen. As such, it had plucked its wings, twisted its spine and pelvis, and separated its legs and arms to reassemble itself into a centaur skeleton. However, despite its efforts to appear friendly to the centaurs, everyone shrunk in fright when they saw Draggy charging toward them.

"Ack...! It's a monster!"

"We're being attacked!"

The panic-stricken shrieks of the Stone and Wind tribe centaurs, who were set to receive the most benefit from the coliseum, rang aloud across the plain on the first day of the construction.

♣

Meanwhile, in the far south of the plain belonging to the Stone and Wind tribe, that is, the most southern part of the planet, there was an ice cave in the Antarctic region. It was inhabited by a creature who had been put into a state of astonishment.

"What is this? Why is time not moving?"

Ice Dragon Tyrannus. The very one who gifted the Heart of Winter to the founding king of Magentano in the distant past leaped to his feet when he realized that time had stopped.

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Chapter 297: The Impact of the Coliseum (2)

“What is this? Why is time not moving?”

Ice Dragon Tyrannus was shocked. He was enjoying his nap, feeling cozy surrounded by the cool air of the cave, when time suddenly stopped around him without affecting him.

What happened? Tyrannus rose.

Grrrr... Rumble!

He dragged his 885-foot-long body, which weighed approximately 10,000 tons, out of the cave.

“...”

The world was at a standstill. The snow falling from the sky hung like a permanent fixture in the air. A deep wrinkle appeared between his eyebrows. At last, he sensed it.

Someone must have used the Heart of Winter.

Indeed, there was something unusual about the frigid air that had spread across the world. He was much too familiar with the mana surrounding him. It belonged to the Heart of Winter.

It must be the Heart of Winter. It’s the only reason I’m unaffected, as I’m the one who created it.

Tyrannus’s furrow deepened.

It must be the doing of that human who absorbed the Heart of Winter.

Tyrannus was upset that the human was carelessly using something that didn’t belong to him.

It’s mine, after all. I made it as a gift for Mikael and his descendants.

The Heart of Winter had been a celebratory gift to the founding king Mikael of the Magentano kingdom. Tyrannus could still remember the overwhelming joy on Mikael's face, as well as his promise of putting the Heart of Winter to good use and his hope that it would strengthen his descendants. Tyrannus had been pleased that he had chosen the right gift.

A stranger who is not Mikael nor one of his descendants absorbed the Heart of Winter, and is using it on his whims?

Tyrannus didn't like what was happening at all. He had to take action.

I should confiscate it.

The moment he decided so...

Boooom! His two legs kicked off from the ground, and two giant wings fluttered against the wind. But he wasn't able to speed up.

Arggh! This must be because time has stopped. I'm slower than usual.

Even though Tyrannus was immune to the frozen state of time since he created the Heart of Winter, he was still subject to some side effects. His movement had slowed down dozens, no, hundreds of times more than usual. His wings were heavier, and his speed of flight was frustratingly slow.

Tsk. I wish I could teleport, but I can't since time has stopped flowing.

The flow of mana in the world had changed with the freezing of time. The coordinate time scale had been bypassed, preventing Tyrannus from teleporting. He had no choice but to fly at a snail's pace.

At this rate, it's going to take a few months to get there.

Tyrannus grumbled again, resolving with hostile determination to teach that human a lesson. He continued to fly in slow motion toward the northwest plain of the Lorasian Continent.

♣

Meanwhile, construction was taking place to build a circuit coliseum at the center of the Klamath Plain, which was the only region unaffected by the frozen state of time.

“Okay, Draggy,” called Lloyd.

Draggy cocked its head to the side.

“Do you see the glowing blue lines?”

Creak! Draggy nodded its head again. It saw the glowing bluish lines and surfaces surrounding the area.

“Good,” Lloyd said. “You just have to dig along those lines and surfaces to flatten them up. What do you think? Do you think you can do it?”

Crack! Draggy nodded once again. It could do the job without a doubt. Though the total area was several square miles of square feet, it was a no-brainer to Draggy.

Boooom! Three or four wielding its tail did the job. In no time, the ground was swept away by its destructive tail, the sight being much like sweeping the ground with a broom.

“Urk! Ahem, excellent,” observed Lloyd.

When the thick cloud of dust cleared, Lloyd nodded with satisfaction and saw that the land was flattened exactly the way the Construction Guideline had outlined. And on top of that, the dense shrubs of grass had all been pulled out.

Haha. There’s a shocking sight for the elves.

Lloyd chuckled as he remembered those groups of plant lovers. Draggy’s extraordinary feat allowed the groundwork of the coliseum to be swiftly completed.

“Next up! Ppodong. Javier,” called Lloyd.

“Ppodong!”

“Yes...” Javier replied with a crestfallen look on his face.

“Off you go!” urged Lloyd as he pointed his finger upward.

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“Whew...”

Ppodong darted across the site while Javier went around with an evident look of self-depreciation, the two of them flattening the areas Draggy had missed and filling in the dented areas of land. They carefully completed their task. Next, it was Hamang’s turn.

“All right, Hamang,” said Lloyd with a clap.

“Hamang!” replied Hamang, who inflated himself to a height of 98 feet after absorbing water from nearby creeks.

“Make good use of all the water you took in to grow. You know what I mean, right? Let’s get on with it.”

“Hamamang!”

Rollll! Hamang rolled around the land, which Draggy swept and Ppodong as well as Javier meticulously tidied up, with his weight. All of these tasks took them ten days to complete. Once it was done, it was time for Bangul to work.

“Okay! Bangul. Push!”

“Bangul!”

Jingle! Bangul dutifully ate the dirt on the ground and produced metal rebars. Lloyd and Javier then organized and cut them into equal sizes and laid them out around the racetrack. The purpose of the rebars was to support the concrete that would become a sturdy layer of ground for the racetrack.

The Continuously Reinforced Concrete Pavement (CRCP) method will be used for the grounds of the coliseum's racetrack.

Lloyd had already finished creating the design for this project in advance. The CRCP method boasted a longer service life than any other alternative for it. This meant it was easier and less effort to maintain while also being more cost-effective.

That's why it's widely used on hot, dry, and large pieces of land in places like Texas. It's perfect for a plain such as this one.

There was more. One of the express highways in Korea was built using this same method. It was the Jungbu Expressway.

People really don't know that rebars are placed under the roads they drive on. However, problems arise if a concrete pavement is not reinforced with rebars. That's how important metal rebars are.

The rebars in the concrete pavement were sort of like a frame. It was the best way to prevent small cracks from forming on roads due to temperature and humidity changes in the environment or pressure from driving vehicles.

And that's why I have to be so cautious and careful when I'm installing rebars.

Lloyd installed the cut-out rebars following the direction of the pavement. Of course, this wasn't an easy job, and it was particularly more tedious because he didn't have enough helping hands.

Tsk! I wish the Skeleton Corps was here with me!

Laying the rebars required a special skill set. An advanced one, even.

Of course. The measurement has to be precise. Everything has to be perfectly leveled, and the binding connectors have to be sturdy.

That was the reason why Lloyd couldn't pass the job to the centaurs, whose physiques weren't compatible with this sort of job.

They can’t even scratch their bellies with their arms!

Their physique was perfect for running and running only. Due to their extreme physical features, centaurs couldn’t so much as scratch their bellies or buttocks without the help of a tool. The same problem applied when they needed to pick something up. Their arms were extremely short even when they bent their knees. In other words, they were completely, utterly, and indisputably useless on construction sites. That was why Lloyd couldn’t entrust them to precisely place and bind the rebars together on the ground. It was also why the job fell on him and Javier.

“Whew... after this, I’m going to stop by the Frontera County. I’ll bring the entire Skeleton Corps here on Draggy’s back. With that, I’ll be able to employ a tireless group of laborers without needing to provide them with meals or wages. That would be amazing.”

The Skeleton Corps was the dream team that every evil employer in the world would die to have. They could be put to endless hours of grueling labor without needing to be fed or paid. The thought of exploiting the skeletons brought a smile to his face.

But for now, Javier and I are doomed to do this job.

Just like that, they sweated through the entire day. One day, two days, three days, ten days, fifteen days, thirty days, sixty days, and then ninety days passed. After three months of work, the rebar installation came to an end.

But since the world is at a standstill, I technically didn’t spend a single second on this job.

That was the best part. Next, Lloyd moved on to the next job, which was mixing the aggregates with the cement Lloyd produced during the last three months with the help of Bangul’s Volcanic Explosion. As for the mix proportion, Lloyd looked toward the Jungbu Expressway in South Korea as his point of reference.

The thickest aggregate should be less than 1.2 inches. The slump should be 4.5. The oxygen rate should be 4.5%. The proportion between water and

cement should be 42.3%. The fine aggregate percentage should be close to 37.7%.

Lloyd strove to keep the proportion the same. He then combined everything together, dug a pool-sized hole in the ground, poured his mixture, and whisked it with Draggy's tail. Afterward, he paved the road with concrete and flattened it down with the help of Ppodong.

"Hey, Ppodong. Roll!"

"Ppodong!"

Ppodong was fully wrapped in an oiled piece of paper. He then rolled all over the wet concrete road like a paving machine from South Korea. Thanks to his chubby belly that sent enough weight and vibration to the ground, Lloyd could proceed to the next process of construction after the concrete was perfectly flattened. Curing the concrete. The centaurs joined in and showed their capabilities for this task.

"Excuse me," Lloyd gently said, "Did you finish what I asked you to work on the last time?"

"Of course! Here you go." A centaur woman flashed a big smile at Lloyd before leading him to the backyard of the stable. When he arrived, the area in front of him was filled with dozens of rolled-up straw mats with each being about 16 feet in width and 160 feet in length.

"My," the centaur woman said with mild disgust on her face, "The women in the tribe haven't been able to go on a proper run for the past three months because we were so busy weaving these mats. Our fingers are also all swollen."

"Yikes. Thank you so much for your hard work," expressed Lloyd as he bowed.

"No need to. We're doing this for our kids to race in a safe environment."

“I am glad you understand. I will make sure to build a good coliseum for your children.”

“I like the sound of that. Make sure to keep your promise.”

“Yes, I will.”

Lloyd then took the mats and threw them on the wet concrete to cover them. This was to prevent the roads from direct exposure to sunlight.

This is how I can prevent the moisture from evaporating from the concrete too quickly. Otherwise, cracks will develop across the entire pavement and cause a disaster.

While the pavement was drying under its cover, Lloyd waited and used this period of time to rest for the first time in a while. Fifteen days later, the mats were ready to be removed. Once they were removed, a sleek and smooth pavement was revealed. Lloyd then threw two inches of sand on top of the track to protect the centaurs’ hooves from getting damaged by the hard ground.

Some might argue that I could have created the track entirely from sand. But the thing is, a race track with a layer of concrete pavement is completely different than one with just sand.

Once the tracks had a sturdy foundation made of rebars and concrete, there was no need to worry about the ground sinking or shifting. It would remain solid for several decades. Moreover, since he added an additional layer of sand, there would be even less damage from sunlight and temperature changes.

Similarly, a track will last longer and be easier to maintain when it is made with concrete. The only thing that will need to get done after each race is flattening the sand on the track again.

With that, the race track was finished. However, there were more tasks that needed to be done. Lloyd installed fences to separate different tracks and furnished the viewing area for spectators. A stable was also constructed as a

waiting and resting area for athletes. These finishing touches took up two more months of construction.

And at last, after about seven months since the time was frozen, a coliseum was built for the first time in Lorasian history. One side was furnished with straight tracks, each extending to 330, 875, and 1640 yards. Beside them was a huge track that ran 2,818 yards north and 1,421 yards south with 19 corners.

I did it...

Lloyd wiped the tears as he looked at the finished coliseum. But he wasn't crying because he was moved.

I'm free now!

Lloyd had to physically participate in this construction throughout all of its processes. He had rolled up his sleeves, dug, flattened, and installed whatever was necessary, sweating buckets every day because the Skeleton Corps wasn't there to help him and the centaurs were useless. Javier, Draggy, and the fantastical creatures were the only sources of help he could rely on. As such, Lloyd sometimes had panic attacks over whether he could finish the construction within a year.

But I did it! In just seven months! I've finished the construction!

This was the last time he'd put himself through a nightmare like this. Next time, he'd make sure to bring the Skeleton Corps. Lloyd suppressed his overwhelming emotions with such a resolution.

As such, he was absolutely clueless that Tyrannus, who departed from his ice cave seven months ago, was about to arrive.

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Chapter 298: The Impact of the Coliseum (3)

Finally, the circuit coliseum was finished. The tracks varied in distance from very short, short, and middle distance. There was also a more complex track with nineteen different corners. The Head Chief Cherokan tilted his head when he laid his eyes on it.

“Hmm, this is the coliseum you told me about?” There was hesitation in his voice.

“Yes, it is,” replied Lloyd as he folded his arms and nodded.

“Tsk,” Cherokan tutted. “This is one eerie building.”

“Is that so?” Lloyd chuckled to himself but not over the chief’s cynicism. It was rather because his reaction was exactly what was expected.

The chief’s reaction isn’t a surprise at all. Just imagine if he threw a big fuss over this construction, saying, “Ooh! What a fantabulous building!” That’d be even more ridiculous.

Indeed. Modern technology was not always praised in this world, and besides, the centaurs were no fools. As such, they would determine the value of the coliseum themselves.

Thinking so, Lloyd said, “Chief, why don’t you do a test run?”

“What? Me?”

“Yes. As the representative of the centaurs, I believe you should have the honor of being the first to run in the coliseum.”

“Hahahaha.”

“I’m being serious. Please follow me.”

The corners of the chief’s lips rose subtly as Lloyd smoothly buttered him up.

Lloyd capitalized on the change in the chief's attitude and guided him to the track. "There are five different kinds of tracks. Three of them are straight tracks that run 330, 875, or 1640 yards in distance for the purpose of drag racing. The other two are complex tracks that are 2,818 and 1,421 yards long, respectively."

"Hmm, then I shall run the 875-yard track," said Cherokan.

"Excellent choice."

The centaurs' propensity for galloping seemed to never change even as they aged. The chief's eyes turned slightly sharp as soon as his hooves touched the track ground. He soon dashed forward.

"Hiya!"

Gallop! The former champion's acceleration of speed was unbelievable. His hooves crossed the finish line in a flash, leaving only a trail of dust behind him. Soon, he was back at the starting line again. Although, there was an entirely different expression on his face.

"Ha... Hahaha!" laughed Cherokan heartily. "This track is something! I am telling you!"

"Really?"

"Ha! Indeed! Ha! Really! Who would have thought?!" He seemed overwhelmed with happiness. After a minute of content silence, he expressed, "It feels completely different from running on an unmanaged plain where you have to watch out for jagged stones to protect your hooves or spiky bushes to not lose balance after getting caught. In contrast, this track allows you to completely focus on running."

"How did the track feel under your hooves?" asked Lloyd.

"Sublime." The chief raised his thumb. "I thought my hooves were sinking into the sand. But instead, the sand acts as a shock absorber while my

hooves still feel supported by the sturdy layer of ground underneath it. This means we can freely propel forward without straining our joints."

"Were you able to race faster then?" further asked Lloyd.

"No doubt about that. Any more questions?" There was a slight annoyance in the chief's voice.

"Excuse me?" Lloyd's tone rose a little at the chief's change of attitude.

"I want to run a little more," Cherokan spoke as he looked around.

"Oh," Lloyd said gleefully. "By all means."

"I'll be back. This time, I'll try the complex race track!"

"..."

All pumped up, the chief galloped off toward the complex race track. His dignified bristles perspired with foamy sweats. The news about his impassioned race at the coliseum spread across all the centaurs of the Stone and Wind tribe.

"Did you hear the news about the head chief?"

"Eh? What about him?"

"I heard he broke his running record that was set during his prime."

"What?! At his age? Really?"

"Yeah. Really."

"How?"

"How else? You know the coliseum built by the human."

"He broke his record running there?"

“That’s what they say.”

“No way.”

“Yes way. Amazing, isn’t it?”

“Let’s try running there too!”

Yearning to break their personal records as well, almost everyone rushed to the coliseum. Lloyd didn’t stop their excitement-fueled visits. For a second, he thought about requesting an entrance fee for the facility but decided against it.

This is a trial period.

Just like how video games used beta tests and how movies had trailers, the tracks had to be trialed for them to prove their value.

The best way to promote the coliseum would be to let the centaurs use it themselves.

To make sure that the coliseum was used by all centaurs across the plain, the facility had to be promoted. As such, Lloyd was rather grateful for the large crowd around the coliseum because he knew that each would go out and share their experiences with it. The tracks were open to everyone without any charge for five days. And on the sixth day, he announced a new rule.

[Starting today, the tracks will run on a reservation system.]

[Minimum reservation number: Two centaurs]

[Reservation eligibility: Participants of courtship races]

[How to reserve: Visit the coliseum management office. Complete your reservation by hoof-stamping the document with your name, date and time of the race, and which track you plan to use.]

[Caution: Switching lanes is not allowed while accelerating from 0 to 60 mph in six seconds or less.]

Even though such a sign was posted at the coliseum entrance, hardly any centaur opposed it. This was because Lloyd had been diligently broadcasting that the coliseum was reserved for marriage proposal competitions. When the following morning rolled around, there was a flood of reservations coming in.

Woah. Is this for real? I mean, what kind of son of a gun divorces their wife and proposes to someone to just run on some tracks?

Lloyd clucked his tongue in dismay. The centaurs were even more obsessed with racing than he originally thought. A number of centaurs divorced their partners to try running on the track, only to propose again to the partner that they divorced. They found adequate opponents to challenge, arranged a race, and reserved a track.

Well, I don't have any interest in their competition over love.

It wasn't any of Lloyd's business anyway. He simply focused on making sure that the rules were strictly adhered to: the courtship race was to take place only in the coliseum, and the designated speed limit was to be observed inside the villages.

Fifteen more days passed. With the compliance of regulations, there came slight changes in the atmosphere in the village. First and foremost, the number of accidents dropped noticeably, and so did the rate of bone fractures and other injuries that occurred during courtship races. This was an amazing change that came from two simple rules: race in tracks and trot in villages.

Furthermore, this proved that the solution Lloyd offered to the chief seven months ago was effective. On top of that, there was one more change that happened within the centaurian society. Their core understanding of racing had been transformed.

“Me and my tribe have come to realize the mindset of a true runner. Only run in areas where you are meant to run and when you can do so without harming yourself and anyone else.”

“Is that so?”

“Indeed.” The chief welcomed Lloyd when he entered the stable at the former’s calling. “It’s all thanks to you,” Cherokan continued, “Everyone’s thoughts have changed because of the coliseum you built. There was also a drastic decrease in the number of injuries that occur during courtship races.”

“I’m not the only one who is due credit. This would not have been impossible without everyone’s cooperation.”

“Haha. You are good at talking. Anyway, it’s time to fulfill my promise to you.”

“You’re planning to tell me where the Taupo is,” said Lloyd.

“Yes.”

The time had come for Lloyd to learn where the Taupo, the second key material for the Jewel of Truth, was located. Lloyd perked up his ears.

The chief said, “The Taupo our ancestors brought in the ancient past was composed of 16 total pieces. And everything is at the peak of the icy mountain in the north of the plain.”

“At the peak of the icy mountain?”

“Yes. I’m sure you’ll be able to find it easily while riding that large skeleton dragon of yours. It stands in a fairly eye-catching spot.”

The chief then held out a scroll. Lloyd opened to find a map illustrating the icy mountain terrains and the location of the Taupo.

“Thank you, chief,” Lloyd said. At that moment...

Ding dong.

An awaited message popped in front of his eyes.

[The centaur race has opened up to you.]

[Centaur tribal chief Cherokan has accepted you as his true friend and ally.]

[The coliseum you constructed led to the development of a new notion and concept of safe racing among the centaur race.]

[Moving forward, they will further improve their safety consciousness until they establish their first-ever set of traffic rules that will become a turning point in centaur history.]

[The laws will be based on the rules you have set forth, and you will be remembered as the greatest contributor toward the development of traffic regulation throughout the history of the centaur race.]

[The centaurs now consider you as a friend on equal footing.]

[You can now increase your likeability through centaurs and acquire RP.]

[100 RP has been rewarded for forming a new connection with another species of creatures.]

[Current RP: 1,755]

Whew...

Lloyd discretely clenched his fists.

I did it.

Lloyd obtained the location of the second key material for construction and established a likeability status with the centaurs as a bonus. It was only then that a sense of reward filled up his heart.

Truly, this was a long journey.

Just then, the events that took place for the past couple of months came to his mind. How he earned the red speeding ticket in the beginning, raced against the champion of the plain, spent seven long months constructing the coliseum, and another month inspecting its efficacy. All of these tedious processes had to be undertaken just for him to learn the location of the Taupo.

Well, technically, not even one second passed after I started the project since I froze time.

What a relief, Lloyd thought, and at the same time, he realized that he had to deactivate his skills.

Since the icy mountain is outside my no-freeze time zone, I should deactivate my skill.

His work here was done. There was no reason to idle around.

“It has been a pleasure, chief,” said Lloyd, “Allow me to give you something extra.”

“Extra?”

“Yes,” answered Lloyd with a smile. Everything had to end in a beautiful manner. Even if he did a stellar job with the construction and earned the centaur’s goodwill, a bad ending was all it took to spoil all his achievements up to this point.

So I should wrap this up nicely. That way, I will be able to ask for his help if I need it in the future.

Life was long, and no one knew what would happen tomorrow. It was right to invest in relationships for the sake of the future. Thinking so, he asked the chief to come closer and explained how to properly maintain the tracks.

“So, do this and that. But if what I am saying doesn’t work, please make a repair request at the Frontera Fiefdom. It’s in the east of the Magentano

Kingdom.”

“Frontera Fiefdom?”

“Yes, that’s my home.”

After providing the chief with maintenance instructions for the tracks, Lloyd shook hands with him for the last time and left the stable. He then looked up and saw the ice wall that was shaped like an upside-down rice bowl. There was also the view of the sky, which hadn’t changed in the last eight months. He saw the sun that had also stood still at the center of it as well.

I cannot believe I did this.

Lloyd couldn’t believe it. Feeling dazed, he opened the skill window and got ready to normalize the time. Just then...

Hmm?

Lloyd squinted his eyes.

Something strange... is coming over here.

Something was coming toward the ice wall from the outside. Soon, it folded its wings and body slammed into the ice wall.

Crash! A large crack formed at the ice wall and widened. A giant head came through it. There appeared a white silhouette of a creature that was larger and paler than Draggy and a pair of icy eyes that was glaring right at Lloyd below two horns.

A dragon?

The moment his eyes were filled with fright, the dragon asked a question icily. “Human! You have the Heart of Winter. Am I right?”

“……!”

Lloyd’s heart sank. His shoulders shuddered. The moment Lloyd was confronted with Ice Dragon Tyrannus, who traveled all the way here to confiscate the Heart of Winter, the moment he sensed unexpected danger, Lloyd put on another layer of shamelessness on his face and licked his lips. He naturally put on a straight face and an innocent act that would make one say, “Oops, sorry. My bad. Wrong person.”

“Me? No, I don’t.”

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Chapter 299: Let’s Make a Wager (1)

“Me? No, I don’t.” Lloyd’s blithe voice and shameless words rang aloud in the air. They pierced into the ears of Tyrannus , who was looking down the hole at the top of the ice wall.

“It’s not you?” Tyrannus grimaced. His eyes shone like a raging avalanche. “Are you sure?”

“Quite sure. It’s not me,” Lloyd denied once again.

“Really?”

“Yes,” Lloyd answered without even blinking an eye.

A look of dismay came over Tyrannus’s face. “Hmm. I must have been mistaken. I’m sorry about that.”

“I see. Farewell then.” Lloyd waved his hand.

“Is that how you thought this would go?” Tyrannus sneered.

Boom! Fwoosh! His thundering voice made the hole in the wall expand, and the ice dragon crossed through it. Lloyd got a clear view of his gigantic physique.

This is nuts! He’s so much bigger than Draggy!

Lloyd immediately turned on his surveying skill and scanned the dragon’s entire body flying in his direction. The results made him gulp.

885 feet in height. 10,000 tons in weight.

They were frightening measurements. What was worse was his speed. Despite his sheer size, he was able to land with incredible ease and swiftness.

Boooom! However, despite his soft landing, the impact he caused was far from light. The entire ground shook, followed by the thundering sound of hundreds of exploding dynamites. A gigantic storm of dust emerged at the same time as well.

“Ack!!!”

Lloyd ducked down to avoid getting thrown away by the storm, and then he saw something. He saw the terrifying sight of the Ice Dragon raising his body right before his nose.

“Speak again, human. Tell me that you don’t have the Heart of Winter,” growled Tyrannus.

That was when Lloyd realized something. *My plan to feign ignorance failed.*

Lloyd’s plan was to feign his ignorance and lie shamelessly. It was possible that the dragon would buy his words and leave him alone. That was the best he could do in this situation.

Of course, it didn’t work. I don’t know the identity of this dragon. However, he must have flown all the way here knowing that I have the Heart of Winter. He must want something from me.

Lloyd guessed as much. The dragon came here with a purpose in mind. And so, denial or deception would not work on him.

He also looks like no ordinary dragon.

Lloyd recounted some events from a while ago. He was about to deactivate his Time Freeze skill when a dragon appeared, and where he emerged from was entirely uncalled for.

The dragon flew here from outside the ice wall where time had ceased to flow.

What was more, he bore a hole in the wall, looked down, and entered inside.

That means the dragon was able to fly here *and flap his wings even amidst the frozen state of time.* In other words, he wasn't affected by Lloyd's skill. That fact made Lloyd tremble in fear.

This one is on a completely different level from the young dragon, Solitas, that I brought to my fiefdom in the past after much negotiation. I can tell just from his sheer size and immunity against my time freeze skill.

Lloyd concluded that he had to tread carefully. He could mobilize Javier and Draggy if things went sideways and lay an ambush, but...

I want to avoid that if I can.

Lloyd received a strong feeling that it might backfire to regard the dragon as their enemy. He had an unexplainable hunch that the menacing creature wouldn't lose even against a trio made up of a grandmaster, a strong skeleton dragon, and himself. Once he drew such a conclusion...

"My, my," said Lloyd apologetically, "I must have been mistaken." Lloyd put on a nervous smile, rubbed his stiffening hands, and bent over. "Please forgive me. My hearing has been off these days, and your voice was too loud. I thought you said the Heart of Winner. Not the Heart of Winter."

"..."

"Yes, if you meant the Heart of Winter, then I do have it," acknowledged Lloyd.

"Is that so?"

"Yes." Lloyd firmly nodded at the dragon. The best way to create cooperation and leave a good impression on someone was to grovel without showing any sign of reluctance. As such, Lloyd hurriedly glanced toward Javier, who rushed to his side, starting a silent conversation. "*Stop there. Don't draw your sword. Don't run, either.*"

"But Master Lloyd," argued Javier with his gaze.

“Don’t even try to touch your sheath. Slowly walk over to me. Come on. Relax. Don’t glare at the dragon. Smile, you little bastard.”

Understanding Lloyd’s message, Javier nodded. He, too, could feel that the dragon was far from ordinary. But contrary to Lloyd, he realized this fact through his acute senses as a grandmaster and three-strand circles that had reached their maximum potential. Javier felt very clearly that the dragon was ridiculously powerful.

Even if I fight to the best of my abilities, I would only last five minutes.

That would be the limit of his endurance. This was the second time he received this kind of feeling.

I had a similar thought when I first encountered Dragon King Verkis. But this dragon seems slightly weaker than Verkis. Master Lloyd might have some time to run if Draggy and I fight against him with every bit of our strength.

Javier made his resolution as he calmed his nerves. Meanwhile, Lloyd, who this time gestured to Draggy to calm down, looked up at the Ice Dragon.

“Anyhow, if the Heart of Winter is what you are looking for, then I have it with me. But may I ask what the purpose of your visit is?”

“It’s simple. I’m here to take back the Heart of Winter,” announced Tyrannus matter-of-factly.

“Excuse me...?”

“Did you not understand what I said? I’m here to take back the Heart of Winter.”

The corners of Lloyd’s lips crumpled slightly.

Ah, I had a feeling that it’d be this way.

This was a sticky situation. The reason was simple.

“Please forgive me for saying this. But you are correct, I do have the Heart of Winter...”

“So?”

“If I give it to you, I will die.” Lloyd’s voice broke.

“Is that so?”

“Yes. I didn’t mean for this to happen, but the Heart of Winter was absorbed into my manaheart and became a part of it. I can’t disintegrate the two even if I wanted to. If I force it, my manaheart and heart will get destroyed.”

“So?” It looked like Tyrannus wasn’t interested in whether Lloyd died or not.

“So, please forgive me for saying this, but I don’t think I can give it to you...”

“Really?”

“Yes. Moreover, your excellency…”

“It’s Ice Dragon Tyrannus.”

“Oh? I see... Great Ice Dragon Tyrannus. Please forgive me for asking this, but you said you want the Heart of Winter back. Does this mean that it was once yours in the past?”

“No.”

“Then-”

“I’m the one who made it.”

Lloyd’s was out of things to say. Tyrannus’s eyes grew icy.

“I don’t know if you know, but I created the Heart of Winter and gave it to my human friend Mikael Magentano a few hundred years ago when he

founded the kingdom.”

Lloyd gaped.

“I still remember the moment,” went on Tyrannus. “How joyful he was. So was I. Even though I suffered a cold from overworking myself to create it, I figured that my gift would provide my friend and his descendants with eternal prosperity.”

“...”

“Yet, you appeared and absorbed the Heart of Winter a few months ago,” snarled Tyrannus.

“D-Did you feel it happen?” Lloyd could feel that things were going very badly for him.

“Yes, I did.”

“...”

“And yet,” continued Tyrannus. “I let you be because I believed that the Heart of Winter followed where destiny guided it. But this wasn’t the case. As if it wasn’t enough for you to absorb the gift, you abused it for your own benefit. Like now.”

Tyrannus scanned the sky with his cold eyes, surveying the ice wall and the frozen scene outside. At last, his stringent gaze came back and fixed on Lloyd.

“The moment I realized it, I figured I shouldn’t let you be. That’s why I flew all the way here to get the Heart of Winter back.”

“Um...”

“Speak if you have something to say.”

“Please, f-forgive me,” Lloyd spoke sulkily. “But as I have told you, I’ll die if I give it to you.”

“So? Does that mean you can’t give it to me?”

“...”

Tyrannus bent over closer to Lloyd. “Do you dare think that I came all the way here to receive your permission?”

At the cross warning, Lloyd’s voice broke further. “N-No, but-”

“I could have decimated all life here, including you, if I wanted to. That way, I would have been saved from this cumbersome conversation and retrieved the Heart of Winter with much more ease.”

“...”

“But I kindly extend mercy by saying only your life will be sacrificed. Do you still feel wronged?”

“Yes.”

“What...?” Tyrannus frowned. “You feel wronged?”

“I do.” Abruptly, Lloyd lifted his chin and stood confidently in spite of the dragon’s icy gaze. He spoke in a clear voice and widened his eyes. But not because he suddenly had a surge of courage or gave up under the immense pressure on him. In fact, he was on cloud nine inside.

Nice. It’s actually a good thing if he came here not to steal the Heart of Winter but to kill me!

This was it. This was it! Right before the dragon could give any reaction, Lloyd immediately and preemptively said, “I am under the sponsorship of the Dragon King.”

“Hmm...?”

“I am the patron of the great king, Dragon King Verkis. That being said, you cannot thoughtlessly kill me. That would be even more improper for a

civilized dragon like you, Lord Tyrannus.” Lloyd’s voice turned more lighthearted as he reasoned with him.

This time, Tyrannus was the one left speechless. Lloyd puffed up his chest proudly and flashed a wide smile.

Yes! This is what I’m talking about!

Lloyd exclaimed happily. His heart had dropped when the terrifying dragon demanded him to cough up the Heart of Winter. Lloyd was scared that the divine item would be confiscated from him regardless of his will. But come to think of it, there was a way out.

If I give the Heart of Winter, I’ll die. And if this dragon kills me, he’d be directly opposing a sponsorship of the Dragon King.

If the creature under his nose was a different monster, none of this would have mattered. But since he was a dragon, it did matter. After all, the Dragon King was the representative and leader of every dragon. Even the most reckless, wild dragon would not so thoughtlessly hurt him. That was why Lloyd went for this plan, and it had an immediate effect.

“Is it true that you’re a patron of the Dragon King?” asked Tyrannus.

“It is the truth,” emphasized Lloyd.

“Are you sure?”

“Yes.”

“Let’s see.” The dragon’s gaze on Lloyd changed meaningfully. Something must have been detected. A glow soon appeared in his eyes. “It’s true.”

“Thank you for acknowledging it.” Lloyd was relieved that his random attempt to save himself worked.

“Tsk,” grumbled Tyrannus, “I didn’t know it was a human that received that brat’s support.”

Just then, Lloyd wondered if he had heard it right. “Pardon? A brat...? Do you know the Dragon King?”

“I do.”

“May I ask what your relationship with him is...?”

Lloyd wondered from the address, “brat,” if they were on bad terms. Perhaps that was why Tyrannus was bent on killing him? When Lloyd’s nervous question was spoken aloud, Tyrannus snorted and spoke.

“He’s my enemy.”

“Enemy...?”

“Yes. He’s my son.”

“Eh...?” Lloyd’s mouth slightly opened.

“Verkis is my son.”

“Ahahaha. My, the King of Kings!”

“...”

“I was completely foolish not to have noticed such an honorable being! Allow this menial human to introduce himself to you once more.”

This was a complete surprise for Lloyd. Dragon King Verkis was related to Tyrannus? What was this? A soap opera? Lloyd bowed down to the floor without hesitating as soon as he heard him.

“Are you trying to flatter me?” Tyrannus’s voice signaled that he wasn’t liking the kiss-my-ass at all.

“Yes...”

“Do you think I will let you keep the Heart of Winter if you do that?”

“B-But as I have told you, my life will be-”

“That’s not my problem.” His voice and gaze were now adamant. “Your sponsorship from Verkis is important, but the promise I made to my friend is equally important. Moreover, my promise existed long before your sponsorship did.”

“Yes, so that means-”

“You catch on quickly. I like that. It means that my promise with Mikael has more precedence and significance than yours.”

“...”

“And I cannot even feel a drop of Mikael’s blood in your body. I take it that you are not one of his offspring. Am I right?”

“Right,” Lloyd replied softly.

“Then you do not have the qualification to own the Heart of Winter. You have even less of a right to misuse the Heart of Winter.”

“...”

“So, I shall take it now-”

“Wait!” Lloyd shrieked. “I am a faithful subject of Alicia Termina Magentano, the offspring of the heroic king Mikael!”

“That doesn’t make you a part of his bloodline,” Tyrannus reminded.

A sense of panic rushed through Lloyd.

“Do you have any plans to marry anyone from the royalty?”

“Th-that’s...” Lloyd’s face turned crimson red.

“You do not.”

Thousands of alarms went off in Lloyd's brain.

"Then I will take the Heart of Winter. I hope for you to rest in peace before then. Your death is a pitiful one. But at the same time, it is inevitable, so do not be too sad about it."

"..."

"You won't feel a thing."

Grrrr... A frightening volume of frigid air began to spill out of the dragon, and he easily turned the Heart of Winter into a broken air conditioner. The solemn gusts of wind reflected that his death sentence was non-negotiable.

What should I do?

Lloyd gulped dryly.

Should I fight him together with Javier?

Lloyd quickly stole a glance to the side. He saw Javier's hand getting closer to his sword. Draggy, too, crawled its body to charge at the dragon at any moment. One signal, and they were ready to charge at Tyrannus. But Lloyd shook his head.

No! We can't outpower that thing. We'll all die if we try to fight.

That'd be the worst possible outcome. Javier dying was the absolute worst thing that could happen.

He's the main character of this world.

Lloyd couldn't imagine what this world would be like without its main hero. And besides that, he simply didn't want Javier to sacrifice himself because of him. Surely, the knight wanted to avoid his own death as well.

Think! Rack your brain! There's got to be a way out!

Lloyd desperately racked his brain. The deathly Ice Dragon Tyrannus. Chaotic centaurs. Javier and Draggy are ready to charge. As he looked at everyone, Lloyd pondered what he could do.

He reviewed all the excuses he could use, a variety of different scenarios, and potential outcomes he could think of. Anything. He examined, analyzed, and predicted everything he could until something popped into his head.

Just then, he raised his head. This was it. This was the surefire way to trigger the dragon and bait. Feeling confident that he'd win with no doubt, Lloyd screamed at the top of his lungs at Tyrannus, who was seconds before casting a magic spell at Lloyd.

"Tell me something! Want to see if a punch from me will make you vomit?"

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Chapter 300: Let’s Make a Wager (2)

“Tell me something! Want to see if a punch from me will make you vomit?”

Punch...! Punch...! Punch…! Lloyd’s shouts echoed across the plain and pierced into Tyrannus’s ears.

“What?” Flustered, Tyrannus cocked his head. A dumbstruck smile escaped it. “What gibberish are you talking about? Are you asking me whether a punch from you will make me, a dragon, vomit?”

“Yes!” Lloyd shut his eyes and yelled.

“Have you lost your grip on reality out of sheer fright?”

“No!!!”

“I believe you have. But do not be too afraid. It will be painless. Loosen up. Everything will all be over as you slowly lose consciousness like someone drifting into sleep,” appeased Tyrannus.

Fwoosh... Tyrannus was still preparing to cast his magic even as he smirked and cocked his head.

Lloyd hurriedly yelled, “I have not lost my mind! I am serious! Are you avoiding my question because you’re scared?”

Scared...! Scared...! Scared... The shout echoed into Tyrannus’s ears again. A furrow appeared in between his brows.

“Ha!” puffed Tyrannus. “Scared?! Me?”

“Yes! I actually have a very strong punch!”

Lloyd held up his fist and boldly swayed it around. Then he slammed the ground after depositing amplified mana into his fist. A rock on the ground cracked sideways. He confidently stared up at the ice dragon.

“What now? Did you see that?”

“Ha...”

The scoff on Tyrannus’s face deepened. His eyes contained dismay as they looked down on Lloyd. “You struck me by surprise. You are as transparent as a glass. I can see right through you. You just threw a weak punch on purpose to bait me into your game, didn’t you?”

“Yes, that’s right!”

“Do you think your shallow tactic would work on me?”

“Yes!”

“Why is that?”

“Because one way or another, I’m going to lose!”

Lose...! Lose...! Lose...

Lloyd’s shout, which had turned sorrowful, traveled into Tyrannus’s ears again. His eyes were wet with tears. Rubbing his hands and pathetically pleading to Ice Dragon Tyrannus, Lloyd wailed, “The truth is, even my mighty punch will be nothing to you. But please think about it. My death is inevitable in any case, but I’ll be able to die with a little more peace if you entertain my silly bet...”

“Hmm.”

“So, I entreat you, Great Ice Dragon Tyrannus. Could you please grant a dying man’s wish and accept my wager?”

“Tsk,” tutted Tyrannus, “But does the wager really have to be over a punch?”

“Yes. I would like it to be.”

“Why?”

“So that...” Lloyd’s voice broke. “I’ll have something to brag about in the underworld. I’ll be able to say I punched the pit of a dragon’s stomach when I was alive. Please grant this one wish. Think of it as gifting me a brag-worthy experience before you send me to the underworld, would you?”

“...”

“You suddenly appeared to confiscate the Heart of Winter, even when doing so would kill me, and I’ve been holding onto it without any problems until now. I am sure you could at least extend that act of kindness, won’t you?” And now, tears began to roll down from Lloyd’s eyes. They ran down his cheeks and dropped to the ground. His nose started to get wet. But Lloyd didn’t care about his unsightly appearance.

Of course, my words aren’t sincere! How could I be sincere right now?

Lloyd didn’t need any story to brag about in Hell. He only wanted to make it out alive and survive this situation as slaving away on earth was much better than in the underworld. As such, his large drops of tears were all part of an act.

“So, please,” howled Lloyd. “Think about it, Your Excellency. I am an honored patron of the Dragon King. Even though you say you’ll kill me regardless of that fact, don’t you still feel a bit guilty about it? But if we make a wager, you will have a good reason to do it, Lord Tyrannus, I mean, Great Dragon King! Won’t it?”

“Hmm,” observed Tyrannus, “That way, I won’t be thoughtlessly killing a human sponsored by my son, Verkis.”

“That’s exactly right! That would be a completely different story. Why? Because then you would be killing me for a justifiable reason.”

“That does seem true...”

“Doesn’t it, My King? Doesn’t it?”

“Hmm...” Tyrannus mused as he nodded.

Come to think of it, he has a point.

It was true. Tyrannus felt slightly uncomfortable about killing a patron of his son, Dragon King Verkis. It was the case even if he was doing so to confiscate the Heart of Winter.

But it'll be another story once I accept the wager since betting is an act of mutual agreement and promise.

So, even if I kill that man, Tyrannus thought, *it will be justified as it had been done under mutual consent. Thus, his reputation wouldn't be damaged in any way.*

At last, Tyrannus nodded. "I see. You have a point."

Psssh... Lloyd heaved a sigh of relief when he saw the dragon pause his magic spell. "Thank you for granting the wish of an irrelevant human!" cried Lloyd in a shaky voice as he wiped tears off his face.

"It's nothing."

"I appreciate it from the bottom of my heart!"

"Let's get right to it."

"Yes." Lloyd's voice was lighter now. "I wish to set the rules to the wagers first."

"Rules to the wagers?"

"Yes." Lloyd nodded and reeled off, "A man's life is at stake. Wouldn't it be better to set down the rules so no one will argue about them later?"

"Well, you are right."

"That's why the rules must be determined."

"Well... Suit yourself."

“Thank you. In short, I am going to lay one punch to the pit of your stomach. The exact location will be in your upper abdomen, and you are not allowed to defend yourself in any way.”

“I just have to get punched once?”

“Yes.”

“And what if I’m unharmed?” asked Tyrannus.

“Then you win. But if you vomit, I win.”

“Ha. Vomit? Well, fine.”

“Thank you for your generosity.”

“Don’t thank me. Your punch won’t be enough to make me retch. Anyhow, if I win, I’m taking the Heart of Winter. Happy?”

“Yes. But if I win, I keep the Heart of Winter.”

“I accept. Although, that won’t happen.”

“Well… I can’t disagree with you.” Lloyd sighed with a bitter and wistful gaze.

Slightly feeling pitiful for Lloyd, Tyrannus asked, “Are we doing it here?”

“No. I would like for us to move somewhere else.”

“Move? Why?”

“We are in the village of the centaurs right now.”

“So?”

“If you really throw up against all odds by chance, it’ll be troublesome for the centaurs here.”

“Haha. There is no way I will throw up.”

“I think so, too,” reasoned Lloyd, “But you can never be too careful.”

“Tsk... Fine.”

Tyrannus was struck by surprise once again. The more he conversed with that human, the more flustered he became. But he was willing to grant the dying man’s wish.

He didn’t rudely resist or fight back because he didn’t want to die.

That part about Lloyd pleased Tyrannus. Eventually, he nodded.

“All right. We will move to wherever you desire.”

“Thank you! Thank you!”

“Get moving now.”

“Yes!”

Lloyd clenched his fists and swiveled in a hurry, smothering a smile. He strutted out of the village, past the gazes of the terrified centaurs who were watching him and Tyrannus in their stables.

“Master Lloyd, have you gone mad?” Javier, who immediately came to his side, whispered seriously. “What do you mean you’ll punch the dragon and make him vomit? Do you have a plan in mind?”

“Yeah.”

“You cannot possibly think this is possible.”

“I do. Of course, I do.” Lloyd grinned with a smile. “And I’m going to win this wager.”

“How on earth will you do that?”

“Skillfully.”

Javier was rendered speechless. He tried to make sense of Lloyd’s plan but failed. He was planning to make the dragon vomit by merely punching the pit of his stomach?

Javier’s face clouded with worry. Could it be that Lloyd lost his ability to make proper judgments? And was that the reason why he bet his life on such a hopeless and impossible bet? Javier wondered. Could it be that the sudden appearance of the menacing dragon and his deadly demands propelled him to make a poor decision? Could that be the reason behind his foolish confidence?

“Master Lloyd.” Javier stared at Lloyd with an unsmiling look.

“Yeah. What?”

“This will not do.” Javier’s voice dripped with alarm.

“What won’t?”

“You are making a bad decision here. It’s not too late now. Prepare yourself, Master Lloyd.”

“For what?” Meanwhile, Lloyd’s voice was cheery.

“To run away. I will buy you some time.”

“You plan on fighting that dragon?”

“Yes.”

“Tsk. Don’t even try.”

“But Master Lloyd. Now is your last chance-”

“Do I look like I’ve gone mad?” said Lloyd.

“…”

“Answer me. Do I look like someone who’s lost his mind?”

Javier was about to answer yes when Lloyd spoke first. “Who was it that said he would trust in my seemingly deranged behavior?”

“...”

“You said that,” reminded Lloyd. “Those were your words. It goes the same right now. Do I look like I’ve lost it? In that case, trust me.”

“But Master Lloyd-”

“I’m doing this for a reason.” Lloyd didn’t let Javier finish. “I’ve got a plan. So, do what you have to do when I fail. Got it?”

“...”

“When that happens, I won’t need to be convinced to run for my life. Okay, we’re here.”

Lloyd stopped. They were hundreds of yards away from the Stone and Wind tribe and near the creek that provided drinking water to the centaur tribe.

“Great Tyrannus, this is the place where I wish we complete our wager.”

“Is that so? This doesn’t seem to be a particularly special place.” Tyrannus spoke after surveying around.

“That should be the case. To be honest, I just wanted to prepare myself during my walk here,” confessed Lloyd.

“Is that why you whispered to that silver-haired fellow beside you?”

“Yes, I wanted to at least bid farewell to him.”

The confident smile Lloyd had flashed toward Javier on his way was no longer there. The moment he turned to face the dragon, he put on the

saddest face he could pull off to match the I-am-going-to-die-soon and I-don’t-want-to-die energy.

“Please get ready,” Lloyd said as he looked up at the dragon, biting his underlip. His face was slightly pale. “Please stand over there.”

“I will do that.”

Boom! Stomp! Tyrannus got into position.

Lloyd tilted his head a little. “I am really sorry about this, but could you take half a step to your left?”

“Why is that?”

“I fear my punch will not land properly from where you are standing right now. This is my only chance, so I wish to give it my best shot.”

“If you say so,” the dragon snorted, thinking that Lloyd would lose anyway and doing what he was told to. In the process, his left foot went into the creek.

Splash! Even though the creek was relatively deep, going down as low as the waist for the humans, the dragon didn’t care at all because he was gigantic. To him, stepping into a 3-foot-deep creek was the same as a human stepping on a slightly wet bathroom tile.

“Well then, let us begin.”

Grrrr... The dragon stood on his two feet and raised his forearms high in the air, revealing his abdomen toward Lloyd.

“Come at me, human.”

“I know.”

Lloyd nodded. Wearing a determined face, he climbed the dragon’s hind leg like he was hiking, moving past the thigh and stomach until he reached the dragon’s upper abdomen.

“I will punch you now.”

“Be my guest.”

Lloyd raised his right fist and clenched it tight. Then he thrust it ahead. His fist was bare, without being supported by his mana or mana circle rotation. The punch was superbly mediocre. The same went for the sound of its impact.

Bam! A soft thumping sound arose like someone hit a table with their fist. That was it. Ten seconds passed. Nothing consequential took place. The sight drained color from everyone’s faces. Javier gravely grabbed his sheath. Draggy got ready to charge. Tyrannus broke into laughter.

“Okay,” announced Tyrannus, “I accepted to make a wager as you said. Here is the result. To your misfortune, nothing happened to me despite your punch-”

Just then, right before Tyrannus could finish his victory speech...

Ding dong.

[<Upper Abdomen! Upper Abdomen! Upper Abdomen!> has been activated.]

[You have struck the abdomen of someone under 20 inches of water. The condition “Any terrain that has a water level of above 20 inches, which includes seas, rivers, lakes, and bathtubs” has been satisfied.]

[The <Upper Abdomen Jab> that enables you to empty anyone’s stomach with just one jab has been activated.]

A welcoming message appeared in front of Lloyd’s eyes. At the same time...

Blerghh!!! Ice Dragon Tyrannus vomited.

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Chapter 301: Let’s Make a Wager (3)

Ding dong.

[The <Upper Abdomen Jab> that enables you to empty anyone’s stomach with just one jab has been activated.]

The lovely message appeared in front of Lloyd’s eyes. At the same time...

Bergh! Ice Dragon Tyrannus clutched his stomach as he vomited and shivered from head to toe. But he didn’t bend over like the humans do. His whole body lurched backward instead, facing the sky as his stomach gurgled and majestically threw up.

Fwoosh! But what came out from his stomach was a cold and frigid gush of air, and as the blow jetted into the sky. The oxygen and moisture inside froze into snow that started to heavily fall on the ground. It was only then that Tyrannus stopped gagging.

“Urk! Cough! Argh!” groaned Tyrannus.

Everyone was at a loss for words. All the spectators fell into a shell-shocked silence. Javier who was anxiously watching as he grabbed his sheath, Draggy who was anxiously firing up his determination to protect Lloyd, and the terrified centaurs who were observing the scene from a distance became utterly speechless. Was it because of the dragon’s majestic gagging? Or, because of the resulting heavy, artificial snowfall? It was neither.

How is it possible for a human to empty a dragon’s stomach?

When their train of thought reached that point, everyone’s gaze traveled to the same spot where Lloyd was standing with clenched fists.

I did it!

Lloyd exclaimed inwardly. He had taken a risk on this. It turned out he had made the right choice.

It worked. I knew the title effect would work just as it was advertised.

Just then, Lloyd's mind flew back to the title he received back in the Mermaid Kingdom and its effects.

I can empty anyone's stomach if they're in a body of water with a depth of at least twenty inches.

That was what the Upper Abdomen Jab was meant to do. It was what Lloyd had put all his trust in when he daringly suggested his bet and fooled everyone, including Ice Dragon Tyrannus.

I mean, who could have expected this to happen? A human caused a dragon to throw up with a punch? Lloyd would have scoffed if he, too, didn't know about the title effect.

Anyway, it worked. This is what I call a real scam.

Lloyd looked up with a smile on his face and met Tyrannus's gaze that darted down at Lloyd. The latter's gaze was filled with dismay.

"How... did you do it?" muttered Tyrannus as he rubbed his belly.

"Um, I simply did my best," Lloyd replied in an equally but feigned voice of dismay.

"You did what? Your best?"

"Yes, My Lord."

"Do you seriously expect me to believe that?"

"Um," Lloyd said as he cleared his throat. "To be honest, I don't know how else to explain myself." He flashed a troubled smile. There was really no way he could explain the system of title and skill options to the dragon. "I genuinely put in my best effort. I believe that the heavens have allowed this miracle to take place due to my sincerity."

"..."

“I am being sincere, Your Excellency,” pressed Lloyd.

“Really?” asked Tyrannus.

“Yes, really.”

“Truly?”

“Yes, truly.”

“Hmm... There’s something off about your words, but it’s not like I’ve got any other choice given the results.” Tyrannus frowned as he looked down at Lloyd. What kind of leery situation was this? A mere punch from a human made him vomit? Tyrannus couldn’t wrap his head around it.

It’s strange. It’s so strange. He didn’t even put any mana into his punch. And there wasn’t any big impact either.

Tyrannus honestly barely felt anything, even after the impact. Not even a tingle. He was about to announce his triumph when suddenly his stomach knotted up and emptied itself. He shook his head.

I definitely didn’t feel much physical force.

For someone to make him vomit using sheer force, it had to at least be the archangel of Heaven or the King of Hell. Their punches would be the only ones that could bring about the same effect.

Or my wife.

Tyrannus thought of his wife, Fire Dragon Kalidis.

Anyway, this is one strange fellow. There is definitely something about him that I don’t know about.

Therefore, something else other than his powerless punch would have brought about this effect. Tyrannus suddenly became curious and wanted to know the secret. There was no other way of finding that out other than acknowledging his defeat.

“I see...” His gaze on Lloyd softened. “I frankly do not know what kind of scheme you resorted to, but a wager is a wager. Since you managed to empty my stomach, you win. Therefore, you can keep the Heart of Winter.”

“D-Do you really mean it?” Lloyd exclaimed.

“Of course.” A wry smile appeared on Tyrannus’s face. After all, we made a bet, and a bet is a promise.

I could lose my dragon power if I break a promise.

Dragons held the great power to cast magic only with their words, and the powers of their words rested on fulfilling them. Thus, any actions from a dragon that caused them to break a promise made them lose the power of their words. Unreliable words lost their effect, which eventually led to the loss of the power a dragon held in their words.

I cannot lose my dragon power like this.

It never occurred to Tyrannus that he’d lose the bet. The wry smile deepened. “Do I mean it, you ask? Do you think I’d go back on my word?”

“Oh... That’s...” murmured Lloyd as he scratched his head.

“Never mind,” replied Tyrannus, “Anyway, a wager is a wager. Since you won, I won’t confiscate the Heart of Winter from you. But are you sure you are all right with that?”

“Excuse me?”

“If you keep the Heart of Winter, you’ll experience a bad side effect from it.”

“A side effect?” Lloyd cocked his head to the side in mild disbelief. A side effect? Lloyd suddenly had misgivings about the former’s words. But the response that came back to him was a sincere one.

“Since it’s a divine item that produces such strong frigid air, it places a great burden on a human’s heart and manaheart. It might now show now, but over

time, your whole body will start to freeze. Slowly, before you even realize it.”

“My body will start to freeze?” Lloyd’s voice was a pitch higher.

“Yeah.” Tyrannus nodded his head. “The mana circulating through your body will fill with cold air, and over time, it will settle in your organs. By the time you notice any symptoms, it will be too late. If I were to compare it to a human disease... Aha. It would be similar to cancer.”

“No way.” Lloyd gulped dryly.

He doesn’t seem to be lying about this.

Lloyd asked, “Is there a way to prevent this side effect from affecting me?”

“Of course, there is. Do you want me to tell you?”

“Yes, please.”

“It’s simple. You just have to absorb a divine item with an opposing nature to the Heart of Winter.”

Lloyd mused, “Would that be to neutralize the cold air with heat?”

“That’s exactly right. Have you ever heard of the Tears of Summer?”

“I did...”

“You’re smart.”

“Ugh...” Lloyd choked up. “Thank you.”

“But why do you look like you’re about to cry?”

“How can I not?” Lloyd replied, holding back his tears and snots. “The Tears of Summer is one of the three divine items belonging to the House of Magentano.”

“Indeed.”

“That’s why I’m tearing up.”

“Why is that?”

“I can’t think of any way to consume it.”

“...”

“Ha...” sighed Lloyd heavily. “It was backbreaking work to clean up the mess that came after absorbing the Heart of Winter. I don’t know how I will butter up the queen to be able to consume something else. And it isn’t like I am asking for an extra scoop of ice cream. What’s wrong with my life, really? Haah.”

Tyrannus didn’t say anything while Lloyd berated his fate at the same moment. Lloyd’s instinct clearly told him that the dragon was telling the truth. In actuality, Lloyd could occasionally feel frigid air seeping from his mana after he came to own the Heart of Winter. The feeling grew particularly stronger when he froze the flow of time. As such, he couldn’t think lightly of the dragon’s warning.

“But Great Dragon Tyrannus,” whimpered Lloyd.

“Do speak.”

“About the side effects. How long do I have?”

“Do you mean how long will it take for you to fully feel the side effect I mentioned?”

“Yes.”

“Five years if fast. Ten if late. Happy?”

“I see,” sighed Lloyd. “That’ll be enough.”

“That’ll be enough? What do you mean?”

“Enough time to find the solution,” said Lloyd, “Right now, there is something more urgent for me to do than absorbing the Summer of Tears.”

“There is something more pressing than stopping the side effect of the Heart of Winter?”

“Yes.”

“I am curious what that could be.”

“It’s not much. I need to search for a couple of important materials for a project.”

“Important materials, huh.”

“Yes.”

“Since you’re looking for them here... Are you trying to rebuild the Jewel of Truth?”

Tyrannus’s sharp question made Lloyd flinch in surprise. “Yes, you’re right. Do you know what that is?”

“I do.” Tyrannus grinned. “It’s the building of wisdom that gives the wisest answer to any question. It was also the shining treasure of the mythical age, though it was destroyed during my grandfather’s time. I suppose you are looking for the materials necessary to reconstruct the building?”

“Yes. And it’s been a lot of work.”

“Why is that?”

“They’re too difficult to find.” Lloyd put on a genuinely bitter smile.

“They’re difficult to find?” Tyrannus responded with genuine surprise. “I doubt it.”

“Excuse me?”

“I know where everything is.”

“Where are those places?!” Lloyd’s eyes shimmered. Lloyd clutched the claw of the dragon’s hind leg.

Ice Dragon Tyrannus nonchalantly replied, “One is in your kingdom’s capital, Magenta. Another one is at the peak of a nearby mountain. Two of them are in my house, the ice cave. The last one is quite far away. Anyway, I’ve stolen and brought two home a long time ago.”

“You’ve brought home two of them?”

“Yes. They were perfect to use as firm pillows.”

“...”

“But I began to prefer softer pillows about 800 years ago. It’s been a while since I last slept on a firm one. Do you want them?”

“Yes! Yes!” Lloyd nodded at lightning speed. Lloyd didn’t forget to poke around to check the dragon’s heart. “I am truly thankful, but I wonder as to why you are helping me...”

“Hmm?” Tyrannus asked as if he didn’t get what Lloyd was getting at.

“You don’t need money from me or anything like that, do you?”

“Tsk,” tutted Ice Dragon Tyrannus. “Do you think I am helping you because I want something in return?”

“Pardon? No.”

“Yeah, right.”

“...”

“I am simply acting out of curiosity. I am intrigued as to how you managed to empty my stomach with your powerless and mana-free punch. Yet, if you

die early from the side effect of consuming the Heart of Winter, I will have no way to settle my curiosity."

"Oh, yes..."

"I am offering my help so you won't die early."

"In summary, are you helping me to make more time for you to settle your curiosity?" Lloyd questioned the dragon.

"That's exactly right."

"..."

"The thing is, even if I help you, humans only live up to 100 years at best. It'll be easier for me to retrieve the Heart of Winter when that time comes for you."

Lloyd clamped his mouth shut. Now, he was enlightened of the reason behind the dragon's generosity. Nothing was free in this world, indeed. However, it wasn't time for Lloyd to be picky.

I should be thankful he's even willing to give me all the key materials for the jewel.

It was rather time for him to bow down to the floor in utter gratitude. Right now, he needed to focus on the pressing matter in front of him, which was stopping the damned restoration of destiny by building the Jewel of Truth. Who cared if Tyrannus forced him to resolve his curiosity later on or performed experiments on him?

"Understood. Thank you. By the way, Your Excellency..." Lloyd's voice faded as he spoke.

"What is it this time?"

"You said two of the materials are in your ice cave, and the other one is somewhere quite far."

“Oh, the last one? Do you want to know where it is?”

“Yes. If you could extend your kindness to me...”

“Kindness?” Tyrannus snorted. By now, it was clear to Tyrannus. This human was brazen and audacious. But something was marvelous about him as well, which made him hard to hate despite his shameless character. Lloyd was somehow ridiculous yet cute at the same time. He made Tyrannus feel the same emotions as he did while watching a pill bug struggle to climb a small hill. Naturally, his voice softened.

“Well, that won’t be too difficult to do. Actually, there was a time when my son was engrossed in researching dimensional shifting magic.”

“Dimension... shifting, you say?”

“Yes. Dimensional shifting. Anyway, he used to send stuff to other dimensions for experimental purposes. He tried it on everything he could lay his hands on that wasn’t a valuable good. And the last key material for the jewel you’re looking for was one of them.”

“Woah.” Lloyd gaped. Another dimension? He suddenly felt like a thick, murky cloud was hanging over him. How on earth was he supposed to find that?

“Then, which dimension was the last key construction material sent to?” asked Lloyd, feeling bleak.

Tyrannus grinned. “Seoul.”

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Chapter 302: How to Allure the Dragon King (1)

Seoul. The capital of South Korea. It was one of the busiest cities in the world, where ten million people lived crammed in the confines of an urban jungle. Life in this city was quite a dynamic one.

Even before the sun rose, cleaners went out to sweep the litter on the streets away. When the sun rose, salespeople rushed to their offices to close an important deal, white-collared employees hurriedly crossed the crosswalk to be at their office on time, and bus drivers drove them all to work. Taxi drivers weaved into several lanes to get a head start over the buses as fried chicken business owners watched the traffic war from afar. Students would send a text to those business owners about an interview application for part-time jobs, while the reports they submitted to their professors would be received with tongue-clicking. Delivery men, on the other hand, would receive credit cards from those professors to buy them lunch. Seoul. It was the city where everyone strove to live their best life, each in their own special way.

And now, several dimensions away, in the guest chamber of the Frontera family's manor that sat on the eastern mountain range of the Lorasian continent, was Dragon King Verkis, roughly scratching his side. S*nore... Phew...*

His sleeping position was impeccable. It was the perfect image of leisure and relaxation in every respect. When the morning sunlight streamed through the curtains, Verkis slowly scratched his side in an andante tempo. When the soft breeze blew, he scratched his belly in allegretto. And when the sound of servants was heard from the outside, his hand went further up to his chest and scratched flashily in prestissimo as though he was Jimi Hendrix.

However, he never ever opened his eyes throughout his entire scratching session. They were too heavy to be opened up, and it would be bothersome to allow light in them. But more than anything else, sleeping was his passion. And that was why he had been dozing off in bed for the past couple

of months now. His relaxed and leisurely lifestyle was something the people of Seoul would sorely envy.

Dragon King Verkis cared about nothing at all. He never allowed himself to be awakened. No one in Frontera County could dare wake him up. Many, including the Skeleton Corps, took up the challenge and dutifully followed Lloyd's instructions to wake him up. They yelled, hit drums and zings, and partied and danced around in the room. But Dragon King Verkis never woke up. The dragon merely slept in the guest chamber like the bum he was.

And on this ordinary, sunny morning today, on behalf of those who failed to accomplish the mission for the past few months, a man with a meaningful smile on his face quietly opened the door and entered the room.

"Ha... My dragon king. He's still sleeping like a baby." Lloyd chuckled. He couldn't help it.

He looks exactly the same as when I left him to find the Jewel of Truth.

It really was. The sight was so stupendous that it was almost admirable. Lloyd soon shook off the feeling. It wasn't time to just stare at the dragon in admiration.

I have to go to Seoul to find the last key construction material.

The smile on his face was now gone. Memories of the past few days flooded back to him, the events that took place right after he won the bet against Ice Dragon Tyrannus on the Klamath Plain.

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"Seoul."

"Excuse me...?" Lloyd cocked his head in puzzlement when he heard the dragon's answer.

What did he just say?

Could it be that he heard him wrong? Could it be that his ears had gone mad after the pent-up tension in him disappeared? Lloyd unwittingly cast a doubtful gaze and wanted to ask Tyrannus if he could repeat himself. But it looked like the latter noticed Lloyd's shock. He gave his response once more to Lloyd's gratitude.

"I said, Seoul. Did you hear me this time?"

"Yes..." mumbled Lloyd. "I heard you."

"It's a city in a different dimension from ours. It is a bustling and luxurious capital of a country with a dense population. Have you ever heard of it?" asked Tyrannus.

"No," Lloyd immediately replied. Observing Javier quietly, Lloyd added, "I have never heard of the place. But in another dimension... What do I have to do?"

Even though Lloyd couldn't outwardly express his dismay as Javier was beside him, he felt dumbstruck.

What is happening? Why is Seoul even mentioned in this world? And how on earth am I supposed to get there?

Lloyd felt stuck. He couldn't think of any way to cross to the other dimension. In fact, he hardly wanted to go there. What if he travels and can never return to this place ever again? Tyrannus, completely unaware of Lloyd's internal conflict, flashed a meaningful smile at him.

"What should you do? Hmm. How about you follow me first?"

"By that, you mean..." Lloyd left his words hanging.

"The best course of action would be to unfreeze the flow of time first, gather the rest of the key materials you can find here, and then hear my answer to your question. Wouldn't it?"

"You're right." Lloyd nodded. The dragon was right. Now that he learned where all the key construction materials were located, with some of them

stashed in the dragon’s ice cave, getting his hands on them was his first priority.

“In that case, please excuse me.”

Lloyd closed his eyes. He focused on his manaheart and unfroze the flow of time. The domed ice wall that covered the region vanished. The frigid air that froze the flow of time around the world also dissipated.

[Time Freeze has been deactivated.]

Ziiing... Just then, his manaheart jerked. No, technically speaking, the Heart of Winter embedded into his manaheart started to feel drastically frigid.

Argh.

It felt like his heart was stuck next to a tub of frozen ice cream. His chest jerked and flinched by reflex. The frigid air, which used to melt away in a snap, lingered inside him like a piece of ice in the corner of a freezer and stayed glued to Lloyd’s heart. The frigid feeling persisted even after he employed the Asrahan Core Technique.

Tsk.

Lloyd sighed and opened his eyes. Now, it was clear to him.

The side effect Tyrannus told me about was real.

The side effect was real. Lloyd didn’t need an elaborate explanation of the mechanism behind it. He could simply feel it from the frigid air flowing inside him that refused to melt away. In addition, he could also foresee that it was going to worsen every time he used the Time Freeze skill.

Tsk. For now, I should absorb some heat using the Asrahan Core Technique and suppress this particular side effect as much as possible.

The most important matter at hand was stopping the restoration of destiny from happening. Reminding himself of this, Lloyd cranked into action. He bid farewell to the centaurs and flew to the icy mountain with Draggy,

where he could grab hold of the Taupo. The reward that came to him was as sweet as he expected.

Ding dong.

[You have attained all sixteen pieces of the Taupo, a key construction material for the Jewel of Truth.]

[You have succeeded in excavating the key material of Aotearoa that was destroyed during the mythical age.]

[This is truly an impressive excavation that will be remembered in history.]

[When the Jewel of Truth is restored, your name will be remembered in history as the excavator who found this key material for its construction.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 2,200 RP.]

[Current RP: 3,955]

Yes!

Lloyd clenched his fists. This time, he earned 200 more RP than he expected. But Lloyd wasn't satisfied with that.

There are two more construction materials left that I can collect. So...

"Ice Dragon, I mean, Father of Great Dragon King Tyrannus?"

"Tsk... Let's go then!" urged Tyrannus right away, instantly catching what Lloyd was planning to say next.

Truly, the dragon's magic was amazing. One whisk of his finger, and everyone was teleported to another space. A pang of mild nausea hit Lloyd, and by the time he opened his eyes, he found himself in a completely different place. He was no longer standing on the icy mountain with biting

winds. Instead, he was in the middle of a completely silent cave of ice where two key construction materials for the jewel were stashed.

“Do you see that?” asked Tyrannus as he pointed his finger at an area.

“Yes, I do,” answered Lloyd.

There were large and beautiful chunks of stones in the deepest part of the cave. “Hauraki” and “Takapuna” were the third and fourth key construction materials for the jewel. This time, Lloyd was awarded 2,400 and 2,600 RP, respectively. In total, they added up to 5,000 RP. Thanks to that, he now held 8,955 RP in his inventory.

But Lloyd was barely satisfied. It didn’t matter if he had 5,000 RP or 50,000 RP. It was useless at this point in time. Right now, there was a more urgent and pressing matter.

Of course. The last key material for construction. I have to find that.

He had the last one to find. If not, the other key construction materials would be rendered useless. The strenuous efforts he had put into unearthing all of them would go down the drain. Lloyd wanted to avoid such a disastrous turn of events. He wanted to get his hands on the last key construction material, come hell or high water.

“So,” Lloyd said, “I have been thinking since a while ago... Does this mean that your son, Dragon King Verkis, can send me to Seoul...?”

“Ha. Is that what you guessed?” Tyrannus appeared to be genuinely impressed.

“Yes, since you said your son sent one of the key materials for the jewel to another dimension.”

“So, you guessed that he’d be able to similarly send you off to a different dimension?”

“Yes,” answered Lloyd casually.

“What a good guess. And a right one, too.”

“Oh, excuse me. Then...”

“What?”

“Can he send me back to Seoul and bring me back here?”

“Hmm. Maybe?” Tyrannus shrugged. “Dimension shifting is a complicated type of magic. It’s more difficult than you can possibly imagine. I can’t even properly use it, but Verkis can. He was the one who discovered it in the first place.”

“He did?”

“Indeed.” Tyrannus nodded. “Anyway, there are only two individuals in this world who can teleport something to another dimension at the exact time period and location as they desire and bring them back to where they came from.”

“There are two individuals?” Lloyd tilted his head to the side.

“Verkis and my daughter, Flores.”

“Verkis and Flores...”

“That’s right. My two genius children. Flores is on a trip right now, so I have no idea where she is. So, Verkis is the only one who can safely send you over to another dimension. For your information, he’d be sleeping lazily in his dragon cave in Gape-”

“No, he’s at my house now.”

“Eh?” Tyrannus stopped and looked at him as though he needed some elaboration. This time, Lloyd shrugged.

“He is probably relaxed in bed and asleep in my house at the moment. It’s a long story.”

“What happened?”

“Well, long story short...” Lloyd then went on to walk him through how he got the sponsorship from the Dragon King and how Verkis ended up in his fiefdom. The story made Tyrannus chuckle.

“Ha. Well. It’s like him. Very much so. Anyway, it’s time for you to go back home now, isn’t it?”

“I should, My Lord,” answered Lloyd, “Speaking of-”

“I’m not going,” Tyrannus retorted flatly.

“But I didn’t ask you to go to the Frontera Fiefdom with me yet.”

“You just did now in a very sneaky way.”

“...”

“Do not take my generosity for granted. It’s not something you’re entitled to,” adamantly warned Tyrannus.

“Please forgive me.” Lloyd inwardly clucked his tongue in remorse. He was about to ask Tyrannus if he could join him and convince Verkis to use his dimension-shifting magic on Lloyd. He figured things would be easier that way since Tyrannus was Verkis’s father. Tyrannus was right that Lloyd secretly expected to be given his help for a second there. But when the matter was brought out open, Lloyd realized what he had to do.

I should back off.

Lloyd gleaned from Tyrannus’s attitude that he might be crossing the line here, so he backed off clean and neat. But before that, he gently asked for one more favor to teleport them back to the fiefdom in one go.

And that was how Lloyd managed to arrive at the door of the guest’s chamber from the ice cave in mere seconds.

And how I came to see Verkis dawdling and idling around.

Lloyd chuckled. He instantly realized from the chamber and Verkis's state that this sleepyhead had never woken up while he was away. The latter must have slept to his heart's content, skipping the call to his wife every morning.

Well, that's a good thing for me. I have something to leverage against him for cooperation.

Lloyd grinned. After clearing his throat, he softly announced, "Dragon King Verkis... I brought your wife, the Dragon Queen, here."

The moment his soft whisper traveled into Verkis's eardrum… The Dragon King's closed eyes flew open.

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Chapter 303: How to Allure the Dragon King (2)

“Um, my great king,” called Lloyd. “I brought your wife, the Dragon Queen, here.”

Thump!

What was that noise? The sound of his heart sinking? The tsunami of destruction charging at him? If not, was it a bell that tolled to announce the end of his lazy life of rotting in bed?

What?!

The Dragon King panicked in alarm. *His wife was here? He brought her here? But there was some time left before my sweetheart came back from her trip! Yet, she’s here already?*

She was, according to the voice. And instead of their cave, his wife arrived at the guest chamber of the Frontera Fiefdom where he was lazing around. What would happen next was obvious.

I can’t be scolded so openly like this!

Dragon King Verkis was an almighty and powerful dragon. However, right now, he was no different than all the other married men in the world. To save himself from the scolding of his enraged wife, he bolted upright from his bed as though he was never asleep. In 0.1 seconds, he rubbed his eyes which were swollen from sleep. In 0.2 seconds, he flipped his hair as he turned to the voice nearby. And in 0.3 seconds, his face froze.

“Eh...?” She wasn’t here. He couldn’t find his wife. Instead, he saw a man with a greasy face looking at him.

“My, dear Dragon King! Are you awake?!”

Verkis stared hard at the human before blurting, “Who are you?”

“Hahaha. It’s been a long time, my king. Do you not remember me?”

“No.”

“It’s Lloyd. Lloyd Frontera. You’re reliable! Beneficiary!” Lloyd uttered in a groveling tone.

“Oh, you,” replied Verkis as if it was all coming back to him now.

“Thank you for remembering me.”

“Don’t be. What are you doing here?”

“My, of course, I am here to wake you up to have a great morning.” Lloyd had a sickeningly sweet smile on.

Verkis’s eyes turned icy just as much. “And what about my sweetheart?”

“Eh?”

“My sweetheart,” replied Verkis, evidently annoyed.

“Oh, the Dragon Queen?”

“Yeah. I thought you brought her here.”

“I actually lied.”

Verkis dangerously glared at Lloyd, who didn’t lose his composure regardless. In a more brazen and shameless manner, Lloyd instead put on a genuine expression of a loyal man, “Yes, I know. I know how grave my sin is for daring to lie to you and interrupting your sweet nap. But the thing is, I didn’t have any other choice.”

“What do you mean?”

“The thing is, I am just an insignificant man who hopes that your heart will always be as peaceful and tranquil as a lake. For that reason, I could tell the moment I laid my eyes on you.”

“What?”

“That…” Lloyd said dramatically. “You have not woken up a single time in the past few months. And during this time, you have not called your wife in the morning either.”

“T-that’s-”

“It’s a disaster.” Lloyd interrupted. “Yes, yes, of course it is.”

“...”

“That was why I did it!” Lloyd raised his hands in the air as if he were doing an act. “I wanted to protect you!”

“Hey, hey,” Verkis said as he swayed his hands.

However, Lloyd was unperturbed. “Even if I got scolded! I believed I had the duty to wake you up! Even if it brought about a terrible punishment! As long as you can find happiness by calling your wife every morning! I thought that was enough!”

Verkis shot a confused look at Lloyd. “Why... are you crying?”

“That is right! I believe that the happiness of a family is of the utmost importance! I uphold the teachings of my wise ancestors’ who said that the peace of a family is the key to maintaining the order of life! For the happiness and wellness of your family! I risked any type of danger, suffering, and tribulation to act on my holy mission to wake you from your deep slumber!”

For a moment, Verkis didn’t say anything. “That’s why you resorted to lying?”

“Indeed,” Lloyd replied as he stood upright.

“As there will be a disaster if I don’t call my sweetheart every morning?”

“Yes.”

“Were you concerned that I’d get scolded?”

“I did, my king.”

“Really?”

“Of course.”

“Tsk,” Verkis tutted as he frowned. “I don’t think so.”

“I am being sincere. Truly. I mean what I said.”

“Breathe while you talk.”

“My sincerity leaves me with no room to breathe.”

“What if I say that you’re lying?”

“Don’t kill me, please.”

“What if I say no?”

“Still, don’t kill me, please.”

“What if I don’t feel like it?”

“Forgive me...” Lloyd fell face down. But he was still smiling because he was convinced that Verkis would never hurt him.

Of course. He hasn’t woken up a single time in the last few months while I was away to search for the jewel. I’m not the one in trouble. He is.

Just then, Lloyd recalled the event a while ago. When he was teleported to the corridor, he coincidentally overheard the conversation between his maid, Emily, and the others as they passed by.

They said that there was a man who had been asleep in the guest chamber for several months and that they were worried about him. Troubled, they say. But the count only told them to take good care of him.

Their chatter overheard by Lloyd allowed him to grasp what had been going on for the past few months.

The dragon king was so lazy he couldn't be bothered to wake up even once in the past few months. And so, there's no way he's been calling his wife in the morning. But seriously, what's wrong with this dragon? I even left stern instructions for Turtle Neck, Frozen Shoulder, and the other skeletons. They were to dance and party every morning to wake him up. How could he have still stayed asleep despite that?

A pang of admiration rushed through Lloyd. It was marvelous how the dragon could remain in a comatose state with what would have been going on. On one hand, Lloyd figured he could use this to his benefit. "My dear Dragon King, do you not feel troubled right now?"

"Me? Feel troubled? Why would I?"

"Haven't you not called your wife a single time while I was gone?"

At that, Dragon King Verkis clamped his mouth shut. It felt like Lloyd hit the nail on the head.

Lloyd smiled from ear to ear. "I believe I can assist you with this problem."

"Assist? Me?"

"Yes."

"How?" asked Verkis doubtfully.

"It's simple. If you could help me teleport to another dimension, I would be more than happy to offer my help in return, Dragon King."

Verkis huffed. "Are you trying to strike a deal with me now? How dare you."

Lloyd's smile broadened. "That's how important the deal will be to you, my king."

“So, how will you assist me?” Verkis crossed his arms.

“I will vouch for you.” Lloyd wiggled his brows.

“Vouch for me?”

“I mean when the Dragon Queen starts to scold you.”

“And?”

Lloyd adopted that theatrical tone again. “When that happens! I will do my best! To defend your actions.”

“You? Me? Against my sweetheart?”

“Yes.”

“You think you could do that?”

“I will try my best.”

“Hmm.” A look of doubt came over Verkis.

Lloyd immediately added, “My king, please think about it. I know you may not be fully awake from your sleep, but you’re in a massive predicament right now.”

“I am?”

“Yes.”

“How so?”

“Because you stopped trying to contact her after a few calls.”

Verkis couldn’t say anything.

Lloyd smoothly continued, “So, to put things into perspective, you tried to call her every morning a few months ago, but she ghosted, no, ignored you,

right?”

“Yes, she did.”

“But what did you do afterward?” asked Lloyd meaningfully.

“I just slept.”

Lloyd clapped. “That’s the problem!”

“...”

“Dragon King Verkis!” bawled Lloyd. “Consider her perspective. It seemed you were trying to contact her for a bit and showing remorse for breaking your promise. Then boom! You disappeared again after she rejected your calls for a few days to teach you a small lesson! She’s probably thinking, ‘Fine! Let’s see how far you can take this.’

“...”

“In other words,” Lloyd emphasized the latter words to make his point, “You’re in an even worse situation than not calling her at all.”

Slowly starting to get the situation he was in, Verkis muttered, “Then what am I supposed to do?”

“Beg on your knees. If possible, find a reliable ally who can vouch for you as well.”

“Are you suggesting that you’re that ally?”

“Yes.” It was working. He had fallen for his plan. Confident, Lloyd rattled on, “I’ll use all the wisdom and talent that’s in me. Your overflowing passion to bring peace to your family! The effort you’ve exerted to painstakingly open your eyes that are heavy with sleep every morning! The divine sacrifice you made of raising your body from bed! I will report everything in detail to the queen!”

“...”

“How does that sound?” asked Lloyd.

“Hmm, I’m a little touched.”

“Aren’t you?”

“Yeah,” remarked Verkis expressionlessly. “My heart is fluttering a bit from seeing an irrelevant human like you trying to defend me. It’s like watching a fruit fly declare it’ll protect me…or a roach.”

Lloyd raised an eyebrow.

“All right. Okay. It’s a deal. I’ll teleport you to another dimension.”

“Thank you!” Lloyd bowed his head. Lest the dragon king changed his mind, he immediately revealed his desired destination, “Then please send me to Seoul, South Korea in the early 21st century.”

“What am I, a taxi?”

“You know what a taxi is?”

“I’ve ridden it before. Anyway, 21st-century Seoul?”

“Yes, My Lord.”

“Oh, I see. You’re searching for one of the key construction materials for the jewel, aren’t you?”

“Ah, that is correct.”

“All right. Do you want me to send you now?”

“That would be my honor. Please make it a roundtrip.”

“Tsk. How meticulous of you,” the dragon muttered and got up from his bed. It looked like he was about to get ready to enable the dimension shifting. He started to draw something in the air. Lloyd waited with bated

breaths to be teleported away. This was really happening. He was going to Seoul.

I will return no matter what.

While a part of him was excited, another part was scared that he might not be able to return. He hoped the dimensional shifting would be ready for operation as soon as possible. He wanted to travel alone this time without any company. The reason was...

“My dear Dragon King, please forgive me for asking you this, but please send me with him.”

It was because of Javier. The owner of the voice came into the room without any warning.

Ah.

Lloyd groaned to himself under his breath. And before the dragon could say something, Lloyd immediately spoke first.

“Javier? Are you planning to join me?”

“Yes, Master Lloyd.”

“But why?”

“I have to protect you,” remarked Javier matter-of-factly.

Lloyd grimaced. But only in his head. Now, he was doomed. Lloyd’s plan was to teleport to Seoul before Javier showed up. But now that Javier was here, the situation had become complicated.

Tsk. Seoul is a safe city, so I don’t need his protection. It’ll be a real fix if he joins me and sees that I’m familiar with the city...

Lloyd didn’t feel too comfortable with it. He was afraid that Javier would notice that he was familiar with the city, no matter how much he tried to

hide it. He could unconsciously reveal his identity. Lloyd was worried. The problem, however, was that he had no excuse to prevent him from coming.

“What is wrong, Master Lloyd? Is there a problem?”

“Oh, no. It’s not that.” Lloyd masked his frustration.

“Then what is it?”

“We’re talking about traveling to another dimension. I’m afraid it might take a toll on the dragon king if both of us go together.”

Verkis, who was getting ready to cast the spell, happily interrupted their conversation. “That won’t be a problem at all.”

Crap! Lloyd’s face turned sulky. Upon seeing him, Javier thought to himself, *I knew it. Seoul. That place must have something to do with fake Master Lloyd.*

Javier received the feeling that it was the case when Tyrannus first mentioned Seoul.

That’s when Lloyd’s heart started racing.

Javier could sense it from his transcendental sense unique to grandmasters. Lloyd’s heartbeat rocketed at that moment. His hair bristled, and he broke out in a cold sweat. His reaction was too drastic for the location to be unfamiliar.

I should go with him.

For all he knew, Seoul could be the hometown of this fake Lloyd. If so, Javier risked the chance of exposing Lloyd to the temptation of settling in the world he belonged to. That was Javier’s biggest concern.

I have to stop that from happening.

Javier felt apologetic for thinking so, but he couldn’t allow Lloyd to leave this place. Settling back in Seoul was the last thing Javier would allow since

he had become the pillar of the family. Losing him now was impossible. As such, Javier decided to surveil him just in case and use force to take him back, if necessary.

Javier casually asked, “Then do you have a reason why I should not join you to this place called Seoul?”

“Eh?” Lloyd scratched his head. “Of course not.”

“Aren’t you?”

“Truly.”

“Then I will go you. Like I always have,” Javier stressed the last words for effect.

Lloyd’s lips twitched while Javier suppressed his mile. At last, everything was all set for the dimension shifting.

“Everything is set. Are you guys ready?” asked Verkis.

Swaa....!

A magic circle with sixteen different layers appeared mid-air as Verkis moved his fingers, and each layer rotated, spun, and zoomed around until all of them wrapped around Lloyd and Javier.

Fwoosh! The starlights enveloped both of them until they burst, spread apart, and reproduced. They chatted, shouted, and chanted until they were absorbed into an unknown time and place and led them through the crevice of their new dimension.

Argh!

Lloyd’s stomach churned at the pang of nausea incomparably more serious than the teleportation magic. He couldn’t tell which side was up or down or which was light or darkness. But it was only short-lived.

Fwoosh! Amid the ripple of mana, as it dissipated, there appeared a familiar sight.

Honk, honk! Honk! A twelve-lane road with loud honking cars. Shiny neon signs and streetlamps were everywhere. Lloyd and Javier found themselves in the middle of rush hour at the Gwanghwamun intersection.

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Chapter 304: Home Sweet Home (1)

Seoul was a busy city. The population was extremely dense for its small land mass, and everything was so centralized in the capital that it had become a societal issue. It was also the beacon of Korean culture or the so-called “hurry culture” that encouraged speediness whenever possible. When all of these elements came together during rush hour, several roads in Seoul transmogrified into a hellish congestion of traffic. One of these roads was in the central part of Seoul, the Gwanghwamun intersection.

Honk! Honk! Honk!

Inter-city bus drivers coming in from Paju and Goyang cities laid on the horns, and taxis joined the noise pollution as they weaved into the lanes. Countless drivers who wished to get home fast altered lanes here and there and turned on the blinking signal to thank the driver behind for their kindness in butting into the lane. As they did so, however, the road on the Sungnyemun Gate became more congested, and the screeching noise of the car honks grew louder. The plumes of smoke rose thicker. And for the first time ever, Javier Asrahan was confronted with the global issue of air pollution. The result?

“Ack! Hack!”

Javier suddenly broke out into a coughing fit that couldn’t be controlled. Right after he was teleported into another dimension, the air he breathed in this new world was...

It smells like the air inside a century-old bathroom.

It was horrendously awful. His throat stung each time he sucked in the terrible air, and his lungs heaved in terror.

The air here is comparable to... Hell.

Just then, Javier recalled the last time he was in Hell with Lloyd and its volcanic ash-filled air. The air quality in Seoul was exactly the same. No, in

some ways, it was worse than how it was in Hell.

Honk! Honk! Vroom! There were honking sounds coming from every direction around him to Javier's dismay. Moreover, the metal carriages nearby were blinding him with their lights, and the bright streetlamps on the wide roads were also hurting his eyes. And the buildings here were so tall, he wondered how they were built.

It's a bleak and savage place.

Javier suppressed his grandmaster-level senses that were in a frenzy, trying to catch all the new sounds and simulations around him. Immediately turning off his senses to save himself from the overwhelming chaos, he studied how Lloyd was doing.

Lloyd, too, looked similar. His eyes widened in shock, his mouth was slightly open, and the muscles around him were tense. He was equally lost watching the scenery spanned in front of him. But Javier could feel the subtle difference.

He's acting.

That was what he looked like in Javier's eyes. Even though Lloyd was checking out this strange place with curiosity in his eyes, there wasn't innocent wonder in them. Instead, it seemed as if he was feeling nostalgic about the sight in front of him. And Javier was correct that was the exact emotion Lloyd was feeling.

Woah. Is this for real?

Lloyd's gaze surveyed around. He was in Seoul. The place he thought he had forgotten and would never come back to. The inter-city buses, taxis, and cars passed the Gwanghwamun intersection. And the flood of people clothed in all familiar styles. The throng of tourists. Unconcerned local passersby. This was a much too familiar scene for him but one he hadn't missed.

Tsk.

A strange feeling gripped Lloyd. He couldn’t show it because Javier was by his side and had to act as if it was his first time in the city. However, he couldn’t shake off the wistful feeling that rushed into his heart.

This needlessly reminds me of the past.

Lloyd didn’t have many good memories in Seoul even though he once lived in the city. His childhood wasn’t too bad. However, the last few years he spent there before his departure were the worst. Life had been particularly harsh for him back then.

Room rental. Construction site. Part-time. Room rental... My life was stuck in an endless cycle.

To earn his Civil Engineering License after graduating from college. That was the only goal that allowed Lloyd to endure through those harsh years, which didn’t even allow him to dream of relaxation or leisure. Lloyd had only recently escaped from leading that sort of life and put it all in the past. However, now that he was back here...

Those feelings from back then resurfaced again.

Lloyd felt pissed. If there was one, the good thing was that he was back as Lloyd Frontera.

It’s really a relief.

Lloyd looked at his hands and body. He was Lloyd Frontera in body and clothes. The same went for Javier. Lloyd immediately signaled to Javier, “Hey, wrap your sword tightly so it can’t be seen.”

“Yes, Young Master.”

They were in Seoul. No one wore a sword around their waist, and that was what Lloyd had told Javier before coming here. That was why he made Javier cover his sword with a cloth. Lloyd actually wanted to avoid bringing a sword altogether, but that would be too telling of his knowledge of Seoul.

As such, he simply instructed Javier to cover his sword with a cloth. Aside from the sword, several more things he had to check over.

“Remember what I told you? Don’t be too obvious,” reminded Lloyd. “Don’t walk around gaping awkwardly at everything you see like a country bumpkin.”

“I see,” said Javier. “But Master Lloyd.”

“What?”

“Isn’t it your first time here as well?” asked Javier accusingly.

“Obviously,” huffed Lloyd. “You won’t believe how out of place I feel too.”

“Is that so?”

“Yeah. Particularly because of those people. I don’t know why they keep holding out such strange things toward us.” Lloyd pointed to one side with his chin. Javier’s gaze followed and saw what he meant.

“Look at those foreigners,” one of the locals said.

“Oh, my goodness. They’re super hot,” a girl beside him chimed.

“Looks like they’re wearing cosplay.”

“Yeah, it’s so cool seeing foreigners do cosplay.”

Click! Click! Dozens of smartphone cameras clicked to capture their image. Dozens of curious eyes focused on them at the same time.

Javier’s face hardened. “Master Lloyd, it looks like they have found out that we are outsiders. What should we do?”

“What else?” Lloyd shrugged innocently. “Walk normally. Don’t grab your sword.”

“All right, Master Lloyd.”

Javier obeyed Lloyd. Even though his surroundings were too noisy, and the strange sights and people were almost frightening to him, he didn't sense any danger nearby. Javier was relieved by this. He felt even more at ease seeing Lloyd's reaction.

I knew it. He's familiar with this place.

Lloyd's attitude, gait, and gaze were too telling. Even though he was pretending to be in a strange land, there was a subtle familiarity that couldn't be hidden. It was especially the case with his gaze that surveyed the whole place. It belonged to the one who came back to his hometown after a long while.

Javier decided quietly. If fake Lloyd's nostalgia and joy prompted him to refuse to leave this city, he'd forcibly take his young master back home even if he had to be dragged back. However, this was the exact opposite of what was going on in Lloyd's head.

I hope I can go back safely.

Despite being in Seoul for the first time in a while, he didn't particularly feel joyful about returning. He wanted to go back to the Lorasian continent as soon as possible. He was scared that something would go sideways and force him to remain here.

Well, anyway, I just have to keep what the Dragon King reminded me. This is the destination spot, so I just have to return here and say the words within twenty four hours. Then I'll be able to go back safely.

Just then, Lloyd recalled what Dragon King Verkis told him before he stepped inside the magic circle for the dimensional shifting.

He told me I could be rest assured since this was a round trip. He also said that this item would be helpful in finding the key material for the Jewel of Truth.

Lloyd opened his palm, revealing what was inside. It was a small compass.

“Master Lloyd, do we simply have to walk where the compass takes us?”

“Yeah. That’s what the Dragon King said. He said it directs us toward where his traces of magic are coming from.”

It was true. The compass was a tracker to find the key material for the Jewel of Truth that Verkis manufactured on the spot. To be more precise, it was the tool that traced the magical mana that had been used when the key construction material was sent to Seoul in the past.

“So, this compass will teach us where the construction material is. We just have to follow it.”

“I see. But there is just one thing.”

“Hmm?”

“What is Sir Ppodong doing here?”

“Eh...?” They were walking in the direction of the Gwanghwamun Plaza when Javier pointed to Lloyd’s chest. That was when he saw. His eyes met Ppodong poking his head out from Lloyd’s inner pocket.

“Ppodong?” Lloyd called in surprise.

“Ppodong!” Ppodong flashed a smile at Lloyd as he answered cheerfully.

Flustered, Lloyd spoke. “When did you get in there? I told you all to leave my pocket before I was teleported.”

“Ppodong!”

“You did get out with everyone else at the time?”

“Ppo-do-dong!”

“Okay. You sneaked into my inner pocket when I was conversing with Javier and the Dragon King. I see.”

“Ppodong!”

“You really don’t have to be so concerned about me...”

“Ppo-do-dong! Ppodong!” Ppodong made a grand gesture with his tiny paws.

“Thank you for wanting to protect me in a foreign land.”

“Ppodong!”

“Ahaha.” Lloyd let out a flustered laugh. It never occurred that Ppodong would follow him to Seoul. “Listen, Ppodong. This is a foreign place, so we don’t know how they’ll react when they see you here. Do you understand what I’m saying?”

“Ppodong!”

“Okay,” Lloyd said gently, “Answer me quietly. Lower your voice.”

“Ppodong...” whispered Ppodong.

“Good job,” complimented Lloyd. “Right. Don’t come out of my inner pocket, so no one will see you.”

“Ppodong...” Ppodong cast his gaze down.

“You want to look around Seoul?” A smile appeared on Lloyd’s face.

“Ppodong!”

“Aha!” Lloyd’s danced with mirth. “That was your reason for sneaking here with me in the first place.”

“Ppo-do-dong? Ppodong!” Ppodong waved his hands defensively.

“Come on. I think I’m right.”

“Ppodong! Ppododong!” protested Ppodong.

“All right, all right! I’ll believe you. But you can’t be seen. You have to be careful. Got it?”

“Ppodong!”

Lloyd sternly warned Ppodong. Afterward, he resumed his walk with Javier in the direction the magical compass guided them toward. They continued walking past the statues of Great King Sejong and General Lee Soon-shin, Cheonggye River, Seoul Plaza, and Sungnyemun Gate. The entire time, they caught everyone’s attention around them.

It was impossible for them to be not noticed. Why? They were wearing Lorasian clothes. There was also Javier’s ridiculously handsome appearance, transforming every path he treaded into a fashion runway. People murmured among themselves, most of them dazed by Javier’s looks. Lloyd sighed.

Tsk. This is bad. We can’t be seen like this. What should we do after finding the jewel?

When Lloyd thought about it, he felt slightly stuck. Since the key material was quite large, the sight of such a dashing-looking man dragging it around would eventually garner attention and possibly prompt a police report. Lloyd shook off his concerns.

Well, it won’t matter if we create a little fuss. I’m not coming back to Seoul anyway. Plus, even if the railing is large, Javier will be able to run carrying it. So even if we gain traction and the police, whatever. We just have to rush to the intersection and say the word.

They might appear on the news. But since they’d be back in the Lorasian continent by then, who cared? And just like that, they kept walking, past the three-way junction, and reached the foot of the Namsan mountain.

“It appears the material is somewhere on this mountain,” remarked Javier.

“Yeah. That seems to be the case.”

Out of all the places, it had to be in Mount Namsan, which was the center of the city. Lloyd hiked the mountain feeling dazed. From then on, he intentionally avoided paths with more people. Luckily, it was also nighttime and dark outside, so they managed to clandestinely move while not being seen by anyone except for those riding the cable cars above them. As they climbed higher, Lloyd's eyes focused on the compass.

It looks like the material is indeed somewhere on this mountain. Hmm. But the compass keeps pointing up. Why is that? It wouldn't be pointing in this direction if the material was in the side or foothill of the mountain.

Lloyd felt odd. He was already high in the mountain, but the compass kept pointing upward. This made his heart flutter but in a bad, nervous way.

Haha, no way. It can't be near the Namsan Tower or somewhere nearby.

Lloyd prayed that it wouldn't. He wished it with faith and hope. But the heavens turned a blind eye on Lloyd. The magical compass clearly pointed to the Namsan Tower as they walked up.

Ah. I've got a bad feeling about this.

Lloyd continued to walk with that bad feeling until they were out of the woods and found themselves on the wooden stairs. They went up, mixed with a group of couples and tourists, who all peered at them with marvel in their eyes, and passed Haechi, the Seoul city character, until they arrived at the outdoor observation deck of the Namsan Tower.

Just then, Lloyd heaved a deep, heavy sigh. The compass finally revealed the last core material.

For Pete's sake... So, the last key material is the Love Lock Railing, the landmark of the Namsan Tower?

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Chapter 305: Home Sweet Home (2)

Eons of years ago, in a dimension entirely different from South Korea, there was a material called “Kiaora” that once illuminated the Jewel of Truth. Placed at its peak, the ornament broadcasted the jewel’s existence to every corner of the world as if it was radiating the light of truth.

However, Kiaora was a shapeless material. It merely copied the quality and shape of anything it touched and was impressed with. This was the case when the Kiaora sat at the peak of the jewel. It took on the appearance of something it duplicated, so no one ever saw its true form.

Even Dragon King Verkis didn’t see its true form either. But he was only interested in moving the material to another dimension. When the Kiaora was transferred to South Korea, it revealed its true form: a metal cube. Like a dice thrown in the hands of a god, it fell into a railing factory warehouse in South Korea.

Clang!

The warehouse was stocked with finished rails, and Kiaora had landed on one of them. At that moment, it decided that the railing it touched was remarkable and wished to copy it.

Crackle...! Right after that, something eerie took place in the middle of the night. The Kiaora copied and transformed into the shape of the rail. It then stayed in the warehouse for a few days until it was transferred by the Seoul city government and installed as part of the railings that decked out the city landmark, Namsan Tower. It eventually became used as part of the “The Love Lock Rails,” where couples hung locks together as a promise of their love and future together. And thus, that was what led these two men from the Lorasian continent into this conundrum today.

“What... are we supposed to do with that?”

Lloyd sighed heavily as his gaze cast in the direction. A throng of couples stood on the observation deck, inhaling the fresh mountain air and basking

in the nighttime view of Seoul below the mountain. Some rested their heads on their partners' shoulders and whispered sweet words into their ears as they fastened their locks in the metal railing. Everything was good except that this very railing was the last key material for the jewel, the Kiaora!

Crud. This is driving me nuts.

Lloyd wanted to clap his hand over his forehead. He was flustered. It never crossed his mind that the last key material for the jewel would take this form. Since the Jewel of Truth resembled The Tomb of the General, he presumed that Kiaora would be a special-looking stone, just like how all the others had been. As such, Lloyd believed that the material he was looking for would be buried beneath the mountain or found on the floor of the observation deck.

Tsk. That was why I thought it would be pretty easy to obtain the material and leave. But right now…

There were too many eyes watching him here. Worse, the Kiaora sat in the most crowded section of the deck. Lloyd felt a shaft of dismay. Could it be that Javier grasped the situation through Lloyd's mood?

"Master Lloyd," Javier called as he cocked his head to the side.

"Yeah."

"Could it be... The railing you are looking at with dismay...." muttered Javier.

"You are right," sighed Lloyd. "That's it."

"I see."

"Yeah."

"So, what will you do?"

"I'm not sure." Lloyd nibbled his lips. "I was hoping it would be somewhere without many people. That way, it'd be easy to take out, and no

one would throw a fuss from seeing us remove the Kiaora. I thought we could quietly carry out the job."

"I never expected it to be in such a crowded place," remarked Javier.

"Yes, I agree. If we try to take this out here, we'll attract everyone's attention." That was why Lloyd was flustered. Actually, there was nothing wrong with being noticed itself. The problem arose once people went further than that. "The people would surely start an uproar. They'll report us to the police and whatnot. The situation has become troublesome."

"Tell me about it, Master Lloyd," remarked Javier with equal remorse. "Why don't we wait for now?"

"Yeah, that's what I think we should do." Lloyd looked around. Though it was hard to tell the exact time since he wasn't carrying a watch or smartphone, it looked like it was around eight o'clock at night. "I think this is the most popular time for visitors. Let's wait a little and start moving when the crowd gets smaller."

"Understood."

"Let's sit down and rest in the meantime."

"Good idea, Young Master."

As luck would have them, there was a bench nearby. Lloyd sat down and collected his breath as he cooled off the sweat. The cool breeze softly brushed against his chest and brought back his past memories with the scents that it carried. Lloyd became sentimental.

The people stealing glances at them and those who were looking at Javier with desire. They all felt like friends and family he missed from his hometown. He suddenly became curious about trivial matters. For example, he wondered what shows and songs were trending these days, what slang teens used nowadays, and what new Galactica and iFone models had been released.

The view and the people here. Despite everything, I want to remember it all.

Though they were complete strangers who just lived in Seoul, Lloyd surprisingly felt close to them just because they used the same language and ate kimchi and doenjang like him. He figured it was because this was his hometown. Even the various couples fastening locks in the Kiaora couldn't look any more loving and kind in Lloyd's eyes.

"Honey," a young lady said in a high-pitched voice, "It's so nice up here. Isn't it?"

"Um, I don't know," the guy remarked coolly.

"Why?" She looked up at him in wonder. "The nighttime view here is so pretty."

"I don't think it's pretty at all. My eyes are completely blinded by something else that's entirely too bright."

"What's too bright?"

"You, babe."

Blushing, she whispered, "Baby, stop that. Kiss me now."

Lloyd clenched his teeth.

No. I take that back. Kind and loving my ass!

Lloyd reflexively clenched his fists. Feeling that the morals of this world were going down in shambles and wanting to re-establish righteousness, he shot a deathly glare at the couple in pure jealousy.

"You," Lloyd murmured under his breath.

"Yes, Young Master."

"Let's just take it out now."

“I am with you on that matter.”

Silently understanding one another, Lloyd and Javier jumped to their feet in rage. They trudged toward the Kiaora, the love lock railing, pushing against the shoulders of couples and ignoring their protests. The two then stood before the key construction material for the jewel and grabbed its bottom half after stooping down at the same time. The gazes they exchanged then burned with sincere anger to purify this filthy corner of the world. And inwardly giving their middle fingers to the couple, Lloyd and Javier rotated their three-strand mana circles at full speed.

Ziiing! Their manaheart became full as giant waves of mana grew inside them and bestowed great strength on their muscles, which bulged with determination to take revenge against the sickeningly cheesy couples around them. As a result, both of them possessed strength that went well beyond that of an ordinary human.

Crunch! The railing was taken out with one try.

People’s eyes widened. They had thought of Lloyd and Javier as a good-looking yet odd pair of foreigners, seeing them roughly approach the railing. However, they never even imagined the two would take the entire rail out. And they were even more taken aback by how they ran away with the stolen rail.

“W-wait a minute!”

“Huh? Huh?”

“Hold on!”

They heard countless couples shouting at them, saying to stop for a second, that they had just fastened their locks, or was just about to propose to their girlfriend! Their shouts grew more frantic. But Lloyd and Javier, carrying the Kiaora together on their shoulders, didn’t stop. Like a wild boar, the two hurtled right through the thick crowd down the stairs of the Namsan Mountain.

“Haah! Huff! Haa! Don’t stop!” yelled Lloyd.

“Understood.”

It was water under the bridge. The two continued to dash off, syncing their steps and pace together. At times, they jumped down several flights of stairs at once, almost sliding down the mountain. Soon, their surroundings grew noisier.

“There! There they are!”

“The tourists over there! You can’t take that!”

Whistle! Whistle!

It looked like people reported the matter to the authorities. A number of men, who appeared to be mountain rangers, rushed toward Lloyd and Javier. Their dismayed shouts and whistles echoed through the mountain. The two, however, were not deterred from running in the slightest.

“Ignore them and keep going!”

“Yes.”

The two continued to run. Hundreds of locks clanged loudly against the metal railing, and the din continued to sound even after they were out of the mountain premises. This time, they were met by two police cars. It looked like they received calls from people. What did Lloyd do this time?

“Ah! Whatever! Keep running!”

Zoom! Zoom!

Lloyd turned a deaf ear to whatever the police were bawling through their megaphones. He didn’t have any reason to listen to them.

Obviously! What would happen if I listened to their shouts and stopped? They would throw us behind bars for vandalism and whatnot. We’d be

investigated, and the Kiaora would be confiscated. Moreover, Javier and I don't have any paperwork on us like an ID card or a passport.

They fit the exact definition of an undocumented immigrant. As such, happily cooperating with the police with a smile on their face would only bring detrimental consequences to them.

"This way!"

Lloyd raced through the areas near the Namsan library and the statue of Korea's national hero, An Jung-geun. Lloyd took the lead, and Javier followed him, all the while carrying the Kiaora on their backs. Of course, the police were avidly chasing them from behind.

"Stop! Stop right there!"

The noise of the siren and megaphone boomed behind them, but it fell on Lloyd's deaf ears. He intentionally ran toward the Hoehyeon-dong district and dove into the twisted alleys in the residential area to lose the chasing police. The view of old residential homes and low-rise commercial buildings came into his eyes. Lloyd was familiar with this area.

"Follow me. Over here."

Since it was late at night, the back of the residential areas was relatively quiet. Avoiding the people's gazes and running along the dim streets, Lloyd and Javier ran through the maze-like alleys until they finally managed to lose the police. Once they were safe, the two decided to slow down and catch their breath as they walked.

After a while, Javier, who was looking at Lloyd walking ahead of him, called, "By the way, Master Lloyd."

"What is it?"

"Did you know all along?"

"Know what?"

“That we could lose the people pursuing us if we take this path.”

Lloyd scoffed. “Did you not know?”

“Master Lloyd?” Javier stopped, not knowing what to say.

Lloyd stopped walking and swiveled. Giving Javier a reproachful look, Lloyd said, “Didn’t you survey the nearby terrains when we were up in the mountain? When everything was out in the open?”

“That is—”

“Whew,” sighed Lloyd half-jokingly and half-seriously. He added in a playful tone, “My Javier. You have a lot to learn. The first thing you must do when you’re in a foreign land is to closely survey your surroundings. That way, you’ll know which area is dangerous or safe. Otherwise, determine where to move in case something happens and which terrains could be used to your advantage in specific situations. Don’t you think?”

Javier remained silent.

“That’s why I scanned the area in advance,” Lloyd said proudly.

“This street, Young Master?”

“Yeah. It looked perfect. The low-rise buildings were compacted together, and the alleys were almost like a labyrinth down here. So, I thought that this place would be a good hiding spot should we ever face a situation like now. And ultimately? It’s as you can see.” Lloyd shrugged and lifted his chin higher. “When you’re in a foreign land such as this place, all you’ve got to do is just trust this big brother of yours and follow my lead. Okay?”

“I understand...”

“Eh?” Lloyd lifted his brow. “It’s rare of you to accept my words so easily.”

“Am I not allowed to?”

“No. You can’t. It’s strange. I have the chills right now.”

“...”

“You. Who are you?” asked Lloyd in astonishment. “The Javier I know is far from being a docile, humble, or loyal fellow. He’s even farther away from being someone who would just nod at my words without snapping back.”

“...”

“You better tell me honestly. Where did you hide my dear Javier?”

“Haah... Seriously...” Javier broke into laughter. “Who else could possess such a dashing appearance but me? On another note, I have one more thing I am curious about.”

“What is it?”

“What’s a phone number?”

“What...?” A look of mild surprise came over Lloyd.

“While you went away for the restroom, a lady came up to me and asked me about it.”

“And then?” Lloyd gulped.

“I was nervous, so I said nothing. I was scared that I might give us away.”

“Yes, good job. I don’t know what this phone number or whatever is, but it’s best to play dumb during those kinds of situations.”

“As I thought, that is the case.”

“Yes, yes.” Lloyd then resumed walking. Looking at the young master’s back, Javier thought to himself...

Play dumb? Like what you’re doing right now, Young Master?

Now, Javier was convinced. Even if Lloyd was pretending not to be, this place called Seoul was his hometown. The way he spotted the alleys and the direction of his steps told Javier the truth. It was equally so when Lloyd enlarged Ppodong.

“Hey, Ppodong. Over there. You’ll find two large statues. We’re going to run past them and straight in that direction. That’s where our return point will be.”

“Ppodong!”

Lloyd and Javier got on Ppodong’s back with the Kiaora. Ppodong then through the boulevard in the middle of the night, so openly and nonchalantly that the panic-stricken cars driving on the twelve lanes across the road honked their horns. The police cars that lost them were now chasing them again. But Ppodong was uncatchable, except for the security cameras and mobile cameras filming him. But Lloyd concluded that none of that mattered.

I don’t plan to come back ever again anyway.

As such, it wouldn’t be a problem for Ppodong to sprint in the middle of the twelve lanes. Even if the video went viral on the news and social media, it would be an event that happened in a world Lloyd had nothing to do with. Furthermore, not a single person would even recognize him.

So, there’s no reason to remain here.

Lloyd encouraged Ppodong harder until they arrived at their return point in the Gwanghwamun intersection. Their arrival immediately spelled the dimension-shifting magic to react. A three-dimensional magic circle emerged, emitting brilliant light all around. The door of dimension opened, and the sight of his hometown, Seoul, started to grow hazy.

Meanwhile, Lloyd stared at the fading view of the city. He only had to say the word that would activate the magic circle. He thought he wouldn’t miss anything about this place. He wouldn’t get carried away by meaningless

sentimentality. He would go back without any regrets. He repeated those thoughts over and over again.

Seoul was just a city he once lived in. The fading streetlamps, hubbub from the crowds, car lamps, flashy neon signs, and the musty air. His childhood neighborhood he had just passed through, in the poorer residential areas opposite the apartment complex where he once lived with his parents. The alleyways were filled with memories. All of it was nothing but a memory that would fade away in the hazy light.

So...

Lloyd bit his lip without realizing it. He whispered the magic word to himself as though bidding farewell to the nostalgic memories of his past.

“Home sweet home...”

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Chapter 306: Changing the Construction Site (1)

Swaa...! The mystifying starlight obscured Lloyd's view, and the dimensional magic circle devoured the entire space around him. Soon, gravity disappeared, and everything became weightless as if it was a piece of feather or a bubble. The darkness and starlight dizzily danced around them for a while until Lloyd and Javier felt their feet touch the firm ground.

"Haah..." Lloyd sucked in breath involuntarily. He felt sick and dizzy. His stomach churned.

Goodness. Couldn't something be done to make dimensional shifting and teleportation more comfortable?

These two magic spells never failed to give its passengers motion sickness every time it was used. Lloyd took deep breaths to calm his stomach while reminiscing about the anti-nausea pills that were available back in Korea. Soon, his vision returned to normal.

The Gwanghwamun area of Seoul was gone now. Instead, Lloyd caught sight of a vintage-style bedroom with a half-open window and curtain that was swaying against a soft breeze. He also saw a sleeping man on the bed inside, who continued to be asleep despite the strong sunlight that made his eyes squeeze. The man was Dragon King Verkis, the sleepyhead who couldn't even be bothered to cover his eyes with his hand or turn over to the other side to avoid the sunlight. When Lloyd saw him, he finally realized something.

I'm back safely.

Lloyd felt it all the more now that he was really back at the Frontera Manor's guest chamber. On top of Verkis, there was one more thing that made his return feel more real.

"Master Lloyd, have you been crying?"

His piercing voice. His chilly voice hardly seemed to rise in any situation. Javier was intensely staring at Lloyd with an observant gaze. Lloyd flinched, feeling exposed.

“Cry?” denied Lloyd hastily. “I don’t know what you mean.”

“The reason is beyond me, but your eyes are wet.” Javier’s gaze fixed on Lloyd’s eyes.

“My eyes?” Lloyd widened his eyes to prove Javier was wrong. “No way.”

“It’s true. They are red and puffy as well,” pressed Javier.

Lloyd cleared his throat, thinking of some excuses to save himself.

“Your nose as well. It is red.”

Lloyd cleared his throat again, still thinking.

“There. You just sniffed your runny nose.”

“It’s a cold,” Lloyd finally managed.

“Excuse me?” Javier tilted his head to the side.

Lloyd looked straight into Javier’s eyes and said, “We’ve just visited a foreign land, haven’t we?”

“Yes, we did.”

“The air over there was too murky and unfamiliar to me, so I must have caught a cold.”

Javier shook his head defiantly. “I seriously do not think that is the case.”

“Why?”

“Because you are fine now.” Javier was unconvinced.

“It looks like the cold is going away then.”

Javier didn’t respond to this. He only shot Lloyd an accusatory gaze.

“We’ve returned home. The air is clean. The wind is refreshing,” Lloyd said cheerfully.

“And so, you are getting better because of all of this?” asked Javier.

“Yeah,” Lloyd argued shamelessly. “You saw how Seoul was a while ago. It was the worst. The air was dirty, and metal carriages made noises as they were wheeled around. There were some individuals dressed in weird clothes, thrusting something flat and square toward other people as they made clicking sounds. Don’t you agree?”

“Hmm,” Javier observed, “You looked terribly comfortable there though.”

“What?” Lloyd squealed. “Me?”

“Yes.” This time, Javier nodded. “If I may, you looked like a person who returned to their hometown for the first time in a while.”

“The heck? Nonsense,” Lloyd gaped in disbelief as if the idea was outrageous.

“Is that so?”

“Of course.”

“Well, if you say so,” acknowledged Javier at last.

“Indeed.” Lloyd felt guilty and also slightly suspicious about the questions Javier was asking him now.

It feels like he’s testing me out.

Does Javier know that I am fake? Did I unconsciously do stuff in Seoul that gave me away? Even though Lloyd considered those questions, there was

no way for him to know what Javier was thinking. Lloyd decided to change the subject.

“Anyway, let’s put this down. Isn’t it heavy for you?”

“Oh.”

Both of them were still carrying the love lock railing or the Kiaora on their shoulders. Hundreds of locks clanged aloud as they dropped the railing to the ground.

“Whew,” grumbled Lloyd, “It’s beyond me why people hung these locks up when they look so ugly.”

“Perhaps they contain a promise between two lovers of a long future together. That appeared to be the case from what I observed,” remarked Javier.

“That’s the problem,” huffed Lloyd annoyingly. “Promise of a long future together, my foot. Do you think those lovers will stay together forever just because of these things? Not at all. So, this is what needs to be done. This!”

Crack! Crack! Lloyd grabbed a lock using the Asrahan Core Technique and gave it a twist. The lock cracked in his hand, giving him the same pleasing feeling you get when you pop bubble wrap. Just then...

Ding dong.

An unexpected message popped in front of him with a notification sound.

[You are currently getting rid of the impurities installed in Kiaora.]

[The Kiaora rejoices over it.]

[The Kiaora will return to its true shape and capacity when all of its impurities are removed.]

Hmm?

The messages were uncalled for. But Lloyd understood what he had to do right away.

“Hey,” He said as he looked up at Javier. “Let’s tear these down.”

“Come again?”

“I said, let’s tear them down. These locks aren’t part of the Kiaora anyway.”

“So, are you saying we should rip them off?” asked Javier.

“Yeah,” acknowledged Lloyd. “Think about it. It’ll be troublesome if these weird locks are left dangling on key construction material for the Jewel of Truth.”

Javier crossed his arms. “Come to think of it, you have a point, Young Master.”

“Right?”

“Yes, although I slightly pity and feel sorry for your petty and narrow-minded attitude that has even come to envy couples living in another dimension.”

Lloyd clutched his heart. “Damn... You don’t pull back your punches even in this situation, do you?”

“I did not throw any punches, Master Lloyd,” stated Javier coolly.

“Don’t you know? Hurting someone with your words is also a form of violence.”

“Well,” Javier replied casually, “Then you should end your life as a bachelor if you feel wronged.”

“It’s not that I can’t do it. I’m just choosing not to.”

“Yes, yes. I’m sure it is.”

Lloyd stared at Javier in disbelief.

“Are you not going to take these off?” Javier asked, turning a blind eye to Lloyd’s reaction.

Lloyd lifted his head and forced a big smile to make sure that the tears in his eyes wouldn’t fall down his cheeks.

Haah. Today is a good day. A good day, indeed. Damn it.

Lloyd crouched before the Kiaora as he held back his tears and began to remove the locks on it beside Javier. Thankfully, their strength allowed them to finish the job in no time. The moment the last lock was removed, the Kiaora started to transform. *Bzzt! Bzzt!*

The ordinary metal railing suddenly grew soft, almost as if it was melting. Then, it transformed into a sleek cube that was a shade larger than a basketball. It was the true form of the Kiaora.

Ding Dong! A message appeared with a clear, ringing sound.

[You have attained the Kiaora, a key material for the Jewel of Truth.]

[You have succeeded in excavating all five key materials of the Aotearoa that were destroyed during the mythical age.]

[This is truly an impressive excavation that will be remembered in history.]

[When the Jewel of Truth is restored, your name will be remembered in history as the excavator who found these key materials.]

[For that achievement, you have been awarded a large amount of bonus RP.]

[You have acquired 2,800 RP.]

[Current RP: 11,755]

This is what I’m talking about!

Lloyd clenched his fists. But there were more rewards for him to come.

[You have excavated and collected all of the core materials of the Jewel of Truth scattered across the world.]

[This was not an ordinary excavation but an honorable accomplishment that largely contributed to the reconstruction of a relic of the mythical age.]

[For that, you have earned a special award.]

[You have earned the right to select the land upon which the Jewel of Truth will be constructed.]

[You can now build the Jewel of Truth on the venue of your choice.]

What...?

Lloyd read the messages several times as he couldn't believe it. At last, he understood what the words in front of him meant.

Wow!

Lloyd could build the Jewel of Truth on the venue of his choice. This meant that he didn't have to travel all the way to build it in the Mermaid Kingdom.

I can build it in my fiefdom! He naturally concluded.

I mean, why not? I should keep everything good at home! In my neighborhood!

Lloyd screamed inwardly. *I have to get my hands on the good stuff before anyone else. My neighborhood deserves all the amazing facilities that are available. Everything good has to be mine, whatever that is.* Even if this line of thinking explicitly captured the "Please In My Front Yard (PIMFY)" mindset, Lloyd believed he deserved it.

I've built great facilities for countless other neighborhoods up to this point!

Of course, it was done for the sake of money and came with a generous amount of compensation. But still, Lloyd couldn't help but feel jealous as he recalled his previous construction projects.

For starters, there's the suspension bridge I built to curry favor with the queen! And the railroad in Hell, the jjimjilbang in the Mermaid Kingdom, and the coliseum for the centaurs. The seokbinggo for the orcs. The Qanat in the desert. Imagine if I built all of these things inside my fiefdom! Our land value would have soared through the roof!

If Lloyd had constructed all those facilities in his fiefdom, the land price would have rocketed for its advanced technology. But he had to painfully give them up to other fiefdoms. Recalling those bitter days, he made a decision without a hint of hesitation.

I busted my gut to find all the key materials. And I'll have to bust my gut again to construct the Jewel of Truth. You know what? Come to think of it, it was me who did everything. Me, myself, and I. So, I deserve this. The Jewel of Truth has to be built in my fiefdom, and to do that. Hmm... I've got to meet with the queen of the merpeople.

Originally, the Jewel of Truth was promised to be erected in the Mermaid Kingdom in exchange for the queen's cooperation. But now that there was a change of plans, Lloyd had to convince the queen.

I needed to make a trip down there to collect the tauranga that I tossed under the sea anyway.

Lloyd briefly walked Javier through the plan. Javier widely welcomed the idea of building the Jewel of Truth in the fiefdom. Truly, he put the interest of the fiefdom before anything else. At the same time, he was worried.

"Are you sure this is all right, Master Lloyd? The queen will surely oppose the plan," Javier said.

"Don't worry. I'm confident that I can convince her."

"Convince her?" Javier asked inquisitively. "How?"

“I’m going to offer a deal that will make the queen joyfully cheer and accept the moment she hears about it.”

“A deal?” Javier gave him a look that demanded further explanation.

“You’ll find out once you get there. Let’s get moving.”

Lloyd left the Kiaora beside the Verkis’s bed and slipped out of the chamber. Afterward, he got on Ggoming’s back and flew northward. Midway, he met Draggy and got on its back, flying half a day more until he arrived at the Arctic Sea. It wasn’t as cold as before. The climate was warmer now, mainly because of the Hell Gate in the sky. There was dry, hot air continuously blowing through the gate.

It has gotten warmer.

The floating glaciers had visibly dwindled in number. But Lloyd paid no attention to it.

“All right, let’s go!”

Lloyd jumped high and dove into the sea. The [Upper Abdomen! Upper Abdomen! Upper Abdomen!] and [Underwater Breathing] skills were put into effect immediately.

When he swam further into the sea, he soon arrived at the kingdom and met the muscular merpeople who easily recognized Lloyd. He was quickly led to speak with the even more muscular queen.

“It has been a long time, my queen. It’s me, Lloyd Frontera,” he greeted.

“Yes, it has been a long time. It appears that your forearm muscles have grown thicker.”

“Haha, your traps have gotten larger as well.”

“Is that so?” the queen replied. “I am sure you do not mean it, but thank you.”

“Please do not mention it. May I reveal why I came here?”

“Of course, you can.” This time, as well, the queen was easygoing as always.

Suppressing the worry that his plan might dampen her spirit, Lloyd went on, “My queen, I have found all of the key construction materials for the Jewel of Truth at last.”

“You did?” She rose from her reefed throne.

“Yes,” said Lloyd, “With that, I am thinking of changing the location of the construction site.”

“You can’t be wanting to build it on your own land, are you?”

“Unfortunately, that is right.” Lloyd acknowledged right away. It was better to be honest and straightforward when breaking bad news to someone. The best way to preserve their relationship was to be truthful and avoid beating around the bush. “To be honest, I earned the right to select where to construct the Jewel of Truth once I discovered all of its key materials. Therefore, I wish to build it in a place where I can easily manage it.”

“More like you have become greedy and want to have the Jewel all to yourself.” Her voice was sharp.

“I would be lying if I said that was not a part of my decision,” conceded Lloyd.

“So? What is your plan?” The queen narrowed her eyes.

Without backing down, Lloyd continued speaking, “I am thinking of offering you massive assistance on something in exchange for building the jewel in my fiefdom."

“What kind of assistance?”

“Your Majesty, the climate of the Arctic Sea has changed recently, hasn’t it?”

“Hmm.” The climate of the Arctic Sea. A faint look of concern came over her the moment she heard Lloyd’s words.

Lloyd inwardly exclaimed when he caught it on her face. He knew he was right. Confident, Lloyd reeled off, “It should be alarming. The Hell gate continues to belch out hot and dry air, but no one knows why it opened in the first place.”

“You’re right...” affirmed the queen. “It’s been a headache for me. I was worried about it before, but now, things have spun out of control. There is no way we can stop what’s happening. We don’t know why the gate opened up in the first place.”

“You haven’t found the cause behind the situation?” inquired Lloyd.

“No, we haven’t, nor do we know how to. The glaciers are melting away by the day. The Arctic Sea’s changing temperature and salinity have put many marine animals at risk of losing their habitats. Despite that, nothing comes to mind to mend the situation.” The queen’s face darkened.

It was true. The Hell Gate suddenly emerged and started emitting hellishly hot air, warming the Arctic Sea with every passing second. The melting glaciers and the dramatic temperature and salinity changes put countless animals in the Arctic in danger.

Lloyd clucked his tongue. “I knew that would be the case.”

Lloyd shamelessly pretended to feel sympathetic as if the story was breaking his heart or the opening of the Hell gate was unrelated to him. And as if he didn’t cause the issue in the first place, Lloyd offered the queen a deal that would make her joyfully cheer.

“If I can make the Arctic air turn cold again... Will you then allow me to change the location for building the Jewel of Truth?”

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Chapter 307: Changing the Construction Site (2)

“If I can make the Arctic air turn cold again... Will you then allow me to change the location for the Jewel of Truth’s construction?”

“Excuse me?” She twitched at Lloyd’s question. Cocking her head, she added, “You’re going to turn the air cold again?”

“Yes,” said Lloyd in a firm voice.

“How?”

“I have a plan. If you give me permission, I can jump into action today.”

“Immediately? Are you serious?” she asked in dismay.

“I am serious,” he answered confidently.

She stared hard at him. “You’re a mysterious human being.”

“Am I?” He raised a brow.

“Obviously. I felt that there’s something unusual about you compared to other humans since before.”

“Ahahaha,” He force-laughed. “That is very flattering-”

“Sometimes, I want to punch you for no particular reason,” interrupted the queen.

“What... was that?” He widened his eyes.

“You’re very clever and competent, yes, but that is also what makes you so spiteful.”

“Um, well.” He frowned. “Is that a compliment or an insult...?”

“Both,” replied the queen with a wry smile on her face. The smile indicated that she somewhat had an idea of his intentions. “Come to think of it, you should be quite familiar with my kingdom since you’ve spent quite a time here. In other words, you should have identified what kind of situation we are in.”

“Yes,” affirmed Lloyd. “I will not deny that.”

“And that must be how you came to bring me this offer that I can’t refuse, right?”

“Please forgive me.” He cast his head down.

“No,” the queen replied, shaking her head. “You don’t have to. I should confirm whether you’re speaking the truth first. So, you can cool the temperature of the Arctic air immediately? Today?”

“Yes, my queen.”

“Good. Prove it.”

“I will.” A faint smile hung on Lloyd’s face. Things were going according to his plan.

The mermaid queen’s heart is as large as her muscles. I did the right thing by going for a direct confrontation instead of beating around the bush.

He had made a direct offer without pulling any punches. He plainly and honestly revealed his thoughts on solving her dire dilemma. The plan was to zero in on that exact point.

Thankfully, my plan worked.

He felt relieved. “Then please come up to the surface with me.”

He went out of the kingdom with her and rose up to the surface. They saw the Hell Gate blazing in the sky.

“I will get to it right away. Oh, please stay far away from me, my queen.”

“Why?”

“You might get swept away by the frigid air.”

“Hmm, I see.” She swam many yards away.

Once Lloyd was sure that she was away, he took a deep breath.

Haah. Carefully. Slowly.

Ziiing... Lloyd circulated a three-strand mana circle, absorbing and amplifying the mana around him. In the process, he awakened his manaheart. To be exact, Lloyd stimulated the Heart of Winter’s frigid air that was stuck to his manaheart when he used the Time Freeze skill. The mass of frigid air reacted right away. *Bzz...*

Eek!!

The mass of frigid air jerked and awakened its spiky energy. That invoked a feeling inside Lloyd like he had kicked a beehive or accidentally woke up a sleeping porcupine. It recklessly sprayed cold mana into his manaheart and around him. This, however, was something Lloyd expected.

The Ice Dragon told me. He said that the Heart of Winter would continue growing and its frigid energy would spread like cancer throughout my body after settling in my manaheart.

Just then, Lloyd recalled how Tyrannus had warned him about the Heart of Winter. He wasn’t to use it recklessly if he wanted to live a long life. At the same time, he also recalled briefly practicing how to employ a mana circle on his way here behind Javier’s back.

It’s okay. I have already tested its safety. I’m using the frigid air that appeared as the result of using the Heart of Winter. Not the item itself!

Focusing himself, Lloyd used the mana circle to carve the frigid energy and absorb it. Afterward, he adjusted the direction of his mana circle from absorption to discharge. He then thrust his hands up and clashed the three strands of his mana circle against each other. Its collision created a fierce

shock wave that jetted out from his hands. More precisely, the shockwave came from the triple mana blast he created from the frigid energy absorbed by him.

Fwoosh! He wondered if this was what becoming a smart converter air conditioner felt like. An oppressive volume of frigid air gushed toward the sky like a giant ice spear, as though it was aiming to destroy the sun. Relentlessly, it rose into the sky and spread out like a fountain of water.

Fwoosh! Trillions of ice particles spread into the air like pollen, each speck freezing the air molecule it touched in the air. The result was an icy storm that carpeted the sky and dropped the air temperature by dozens of degrees. The frigid air spread across the Arctic sky and sea beneath it.

Craaack...! Crack! Soon, the larger part of the sea thickened like a yogurt smoothie until it merged and solidified into an icy glacier. The terraforming, no, Arctic forming, was a success.

Huff, huff! Lloyd breathed heavily once he finished discharging the frigid air. He brought his shaky hands to his thigh and pinched it hard.

“Ouch!”

The bruising pinch on his inner thigh sharpened his senses. He hurriedly shook his head and inspected his insides.

Whew. I almost passed out on the spot. Dang, I should avoid using this again if I can.

It gave him the shudders. Lloyd had believed that discharging the frigid air in his system, which came as a side effect of possessing the Heart of Winter, would be possible if he amplified it with his mana circle. And that was why he had tested it on his way here on top of Draggy, rotating his mana circle and triggering the frigid air inside him. Now that he used it in real life, he learned the experience was poles apart from what he tried in practice.

I almost died there.

Lloyd clicked his tongue. It felt like his internal organs were being pulled out for display the moment the frigid energy left his body. On top of that, he even felt like his soul was being taken out as well. However, his efforts weren't without results.

Thankfully, the frigid energy stuck to my manaheart was reduced to a significant degree.

The amount of frigid air that came as a side effect of possessing the Heart of Winter was reduced by one-third. Lloyd figured it was because he had discharged a portion of it.

Well, this is an effect I didn't expect.

It looked like so. The frigid energy building inside him was an ill effect of absorbing the Heart of Winter. It stuck to his manaheart like cancer. But once he risked gushing some out through his mana circle, he was able to significantly decrease the amount of frigid energy inside him.

This could be useful if I put it to good use. I may be able to significantly delay or prevent this side effect from getting worse.

But since it would strain his body and could be only discharged when it was built up in his system, Lloyd couldn't release the frigid energy whenever he pleased.

Come to think of it, this might be the same as those aircraft games when you save up all your bombs before blasting them off simultaneously.

A wry smile escaped Lloyd as the thought popped into his head. On further thought, it really was like those kinds of games. Using the Time Freeze skill would build up frigid energy in his manaheart, but he could always discharge it through a mana circle.

So, in a way, I've gained one more lethal move I can use during emergencies.

This wasn’t a bad outcome. With that, Lloyd concluded his thoughts. He turned and found the queen approaching his side.

“What do you think?” asked Lloyd as he crossed his arms.

“...”

“Do you... feel that the air is still not cold enough?”

“No, it’s not that.” The queen spoke, feeling slightly dumbstruck. “Who on earth are you?”

“My name is Lloyd Frontera. A friend of yours, the jjimjilbang constructor who looks quite handsome if you look closely and whose charming presence can be felt with a mere glance—”

“Cut the bullcrap. Are you a magician?”

“Well, something like that,” Lloyd said with a wry smile on his face. There was no other way to explain what he just did. “It’s all because I recently came to absorb a divine item that has proved to be quite useful. Though it puts a slight toll on my body, it allows me to utilize this trick. Anyway, what do you think? The way I see it, the weather has become quite cold.”

“More than quite, it’s excellent.”

“Really?”

“Of course.” She nodded as she surveyed around with a satisfying gaze. “It has been a long time since I enjoyed such a cool breeze up here on land. I feel cool. Refreshed, and also relaxed. But at the same time, I’m still concerned.”

“Concerned?”

“I am assuming this cold breeze is only going to last a few months. Is that correct?”

“Yes, it probably will.” Lloyd nodded. Acknowledging her as he stared at the Hell gate, he said, “Since that thing is still hanging there.”

“It should be. Even though the air has become cooler for now, the hot breeze will continue to come out of the Hell Gate.”

“You are right, My Queen,” Lloyd said. “What I did was a temporary solution that will only last a few months.”

“Then what’s the permanent solution?” There was eagerness in her voice.

“The Hell Gate will likely need to be closed. I can take care of that for you,” he promised.

“Is there a way?”

“I will find it out once the construction for the Jewel of Truth is completed. I can ask for a solution then.”

“Excellent.” Now, the lines on her forehead have disappeared. But her eyes were still discreet. “Then are you going to make sure that the Hell Gate will be shut off once and for all? In exchange for building the Jewel of Truth in your fiefdom?”

“Yes, that is right. That is if your majesty is willing to cooperate.”

“Hmm.” The queen pondered, but not for long. “Okay. I will trust your words.”

“Thank you, My Queen. Now, moving on...”

As soon as she nodded, Lloyd fished out two oiled pieces of paper from his pocket.

“This is a contract. Please check over it thoroughly.”

“...”

“In exchange for constructing the Jewel of Truth in my fiefdom, I, Lloyd Frontera, will solve the warming phenomenon in the Mermaid Kingdom and Arctic Sea and close off the Hell Gate. In addition, once the Jewel of Truth is constructed, your kingdom and the mermaid queen will enjoy fair access to the jewel. That’s what the content of the contract is about.”

“Hmm. A contract.”

“It’s always better to make certain of everything. That way, our promise will be left as evidence.”

“Well, you are right.” Queen’s gaze carefully went over the contract. Truly, its content was pretty much what Lloyd had said it was. She fell into contemplation.

I’ll be closing off the Hell Gate in exchange for foregoing the construction site of the jewel to him. On second thought, this is not a trade-off. No, this deal will certainly be beneficial for our kingdom.

That was her conclusion. Although the Jewel of Truth was a treasure that belonged to her kingdom, it was now nothing but an ancient legend. The jewel was completely non-existent in everyone’s minds after the mythical age, and they did just fine the past countless years without it. They didn’t even feel the need for it even now.

However, then this human came to unearth it.

Without Lloyd Frontera, the queen believed that the jewel wouldn’t have ever been brought to light again.

Furthermore, there will be an equal amount of risk to the reward we gain by building the jewel in the kingdom.

Queen looked back on the lessons that came from the mythical age. During this period, every creature in existence yearned to get their hands on the Jewel of Truth because it offered the wisest answer to any question that was asked. It was regarded as the most powerful weapon in the world. Thus,

everyone fought to monopolize the jewel, and a war broke out that eventually led to the end of the mythical age. It was a terrible war.

In the end, the jewel was destroyed. The war was said to have taken away the land of my ancestors. Yet, if the jewel is built inside my kingdom today... There's no guarantee that history won't repeat itself.

It may not happen soon. But once the news of the jewel spread, there would be greedy forces awaiting them. Then, the Mermaid Kingdom could turn into a battlefield.

But if I give it to Lloyd's fiefdom...

The risk could be passed over to him. But since the ownership over the jewel would be a joint one, they would enjoy its benefit just as equally. A wry smile escaped the queen when her thought reached that far.

My. His suggestion took these considerations of mine into account.

A scoff escaped her at the realization that she was fooled really well. But strangely, she didn't feel bad as she could feel Lloyd's consideration of his offer.

In all honesty, he could have unilaterally made a decision for himself without informing us. No, that is what most of those selfish humans would have done.

But Lloyd didn't. It was likely bothersome for him to come all the way here, and he had to have some greed creeping inside him. But he nonetheless requested a proper negotiation and offered a nice deal that pleased both parties. As such, this wasn't something she should refuse. It was instead a contract she should happily accept.

"All right. I like it. Let's sign the contract." The queen beamed in satisfaction.

A similar smile appeared on Lloyd's face. This marked a crucial moment in history. The most powerful treasure of the mythical age was going to be

built in the Frontera fiefdom.

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Chapter 308: Changing the Construction Site (3)

“Good. I like it. Let’s sign the contract.”

The queen reached out and shook hands with Lloyd. Even though the strength in her forearm and grip almost crushed his hands, he managed to put on a big smile.

Okay. It’s done. The contract was successfully signed.

A sense of relief rushed through him, whose heart surged with the joy of closing a deal.

It was surprisingly harder than I expected.

Lloyd did offer a sweet deal to the queen. Even still, however, a part of him was worried that the contract might not pull through. It was because of the innate greed that everyone possessed.

The queen could have acted avariciously to monopolize the Jewel of Truth all to herself. That was a possibility I couldn’t rule out.

Greed came without any warnings. Even though it was Lloyd who had dug up the Jewel of Truth and brought it out to light, the prospect of using the jewel might have changed things for her. If so, greed would have crept into her mind at least once—desires to monopolize the jewel at the opportunity for her to stake her claim. No deal in the world would have appealed to her, and any contract from him would have been rejected. However, to Lloyd’s relief, the result was good.

It’s good that she’s a big-hearted woman.

It turned out that she was much more generous than he had pegged, and such quality must have prompted her to objectively weigh her options and look at the bigger picture. This outcome was very ideal for Lloyd.

And this way, I’ll be able to work without a guilty conscience.

To be honest, Lloyd, too, had some greed in him. How could he not? He was tempted to bypass the Mermaid Kingdom and construct the Jewel of Truth in his fiefdom without any input from them. Who cared if the queen protested? He could have ignored her. That was the convenient way of doing things. Frankly, it was a temptation that was almost too sweet to resist.

That wouldn't have been difficult to do. As for the pieces of tauranga, I could have ordered Draggy to fish them out from the Mermaid Kingdom.

The merpeople were ignorant of Draggy's connection with Lloyd. As such, even if Draggy sneaked in and stole the stones, he wouldn't be subjected to any suspicion.

Plus, there wouldn't have been any hardships in secretly carrying out the construction in my fiefdom. It would be a struggle for the merpeople to come up on land. And since my fiefdom sits in the inland area of the east, there would be no way for them to notice the construction was happening in my fiefdom.

Therefore, Lloyd simply had to listen to the voices of his greed to proceed with the construction behind their backs. But he didn't. Why? Simple. He regarded it to be a trashy thing to do.

If I did that, I'd be the same as those construction companies that suck their subcontractors dry while they stuff their big bellies.

If Lloyd broke the promise to build the Jewel of Truth in the Mermaid Kingdom in exchange for their cooperation and stabbed their backs by secretly building it in his fiefdom, he would be the same as the construction companies that promised their subcontractors with new jobs as long as they endured poor working conditions, low payment for their current project, and then replaced them with other cheaper subcontractors afterward.

Lloyd would be doing just what the evil construction companies do. Sure, even though Lloyd frequently went around duping people with his words, he didn't want to become someone who abandoned those who helped him. That was a line he wouldn't cross. So...

Thank you for recognizing my sincerity.

Lloyd felt thankful to the queen. At the same time, he felt guilty about opening up the Hell Gate. It was his fault that it opened up. Even though the Lava Giant made it inevitable and even though he didn't tell the queen about it since he was afraid of getting beaten to a pulp, he was determined to help her.

I'm sorry. I'll close the gate for you, come rain or shine.

Once the Jewel of Truth became operational, there was a chance he could find a way to convince the King of Hell to close the gate, Lloyd thought. Anticipating such, he buckled down and got to work. Now that he managed to earn the queen's approval and signature on the contract, he didn't want to waste any time.

"Thank you, Queen. In appreciation of your cooperation, I shall do my best to construct the Jewel of Truth."

After a quick greeting, Lloyd and Javier swam into the deep sea until they arrived at the site of the jewel. They took the pieces of tauranga and the sculpture, which Lloyd had plugged into the lot when they first unearthed it. The merpeople provided them with help in this process.

Numerous muscular merpeople transferred the pieces of tauranga and sculptures to the land above them. Everything after that was smooth sailing. Lloyd summoned Draggy once the merpeople swam back into the sea and threw both of the materials on its back. With that, he flew southward to his fiefdom.

Large sedans offer the best ride comfort, and large vehicles offer the best seats.

Thanks to Draggy's giant body, their ride back home was extremely smooth despite the high-altitude flight. Several hours later, he arrived at this fiefdom.

"I-It's the Bone Dragon!" A farmer howled in the Maritz Wetland.

Lloyd passed the shouting farmer and directed Draggy to circle his fiefdom before landing at the peak of a small hill, which housed the Frontera manor.

Boom!

A commotion broke out in the manor's front yard. It was unsurprising as the Bone Dragon had emerged abruptly in front of the manor. But the uproar wasn't that of fear or chaos. It was the opposite.

"It's the Bone Dragon! It's really the Bone Dragon!"

"Master Lloyd is here with the Bone Dragon!"

"Master Lloyd! Hurray!"

"Hail to Her Majesty!"

The first to erupt in joy were the fiefdom guards, who were joined by the quick-footed residents who flocked over together the moment they saw the Bone Dragon in the sky. Even though the Bone Dragon produced a giant dust storm as it landed and manifested menacing force, hardly anyone was scared of it. Lloyd realized something from this.

The news from the capital must have spread here, too.

Abruptly, Lloyd's mind flew back to his visit to the capital to find the Taurangas. Lloyd became the queen's meritorious retainer for saving her face. The banquet was held wherein Draggy made a debut, announced to be under the queen's guidance, and then dispatched to Lloyd's fiefdom.

The news must have spread here. But, come on. What's wrong with these people? Even if they heard the news, aren't they supposed to be scared, or at least flinch, in the presence of a giant dragon?

Such a thought came to him. But the villagers weren't afraid at all. Lloyd could take a guess why.

Ppodong, Bangul, Hamang, and Bibeong. These people have been overexposed to giant creatures on a regular basis.

A wry smile escaped Lloyd at the thought. It deepened when he got off Draggy's back.

"Hey, Explain yourself. How did a menial human like you come to rule over the Bone Dragon?" Faster than anybody, with a frightened look on his face, Red Dragon Solitas welcomed Lloyd. The question was so demanding that Lloyd didn't have time to return his greeting.

Lloyd smiled. "Well, it just happened somehow. Let's say that I saved the soul of the owner of this skeleton from being damned to Hell. Anyway, have you been able to overcome your awful craftsmanship skills?"

"That goes without saying," huffed Solitas arrogantly. "I am a great dragon. Nothing is impossible for me."

"Oh, is that so?" replied Lloyd with amusement in his voice.

"Obviously. I've completely mastered wood carving. I'm now onto carving pebbles."

"Wow." Lloyd raised his thumb.

"Once I finish that, I plan to move on to metal, animal bones and horns, and gemstones."

"Oh, wow." Lloyd raised another thumb.

"Then I should be able to collect mountains of gems and get married.

"Woah! That is excellent," expressed Lloyd.

"Isn't it?"

"Yes," affirmed Lloyd. "And until you do, please burn the sludge for us with all of your might."

"..."

“One more thing,” Lloyd asked, “Considering your great lineage as a dragon, um, have you recently felt anything strange?”

“Feel something strange? What do you mean?” asked Solitas.

“For example, like the energy of a massively powerful creature nearby or something similar.”

“No, I didn’t feel anything like that.”

“Is that so?”

“Of course,” Solitas puffed insolently. “There is no way I will detect a creature that’s more noble and greater than me in this good-for-nothing fiefdom of humans.”

“Oh, sure, sure,” drawled Lloyd. “You’re probably right.”

Lloyd couldn’t help but smile again. He had thrown the question just to see how Solitas answered. But it turned out that Solitas, who was still wet behind the ears, had not noticed the presence of Dragon King Verkis. Regardless, before Solitas could probe further, he was met with pushback from the fiefdom’s guards.

“How dare you! No way! Get away from Master Lloyd, you lowly apprentice blacksmith!” Sir Bayern, the senior knight and commander of the Engineering Corps, bellowed.

Solitas flinched at their shout, and a look of rage appeared on his face. But it dissipated a second later when he remembered the terms of his contract with Lloyd. He quickly became relaxed again.

When Solitas moved away, Sir Bayern sincerely expressed his respects to Lloyd. “Master Lloyd, it has been ages.”

“That’s right,” replied Lloyd. “It has been ages, Sir Bayern. Have you been well?”

“Of course, Young Master. The waterways, apartment complexes, and other facilities have been being maintained without any issues.”

“Perfect. You have been doing a great job.”

With that, Lloyd moved on to the crowds of guards, Engineering Corps, Skeleton Corps, and residents. Everyone showered him with gazes of warmth, reverence, and admiration. This weirded Lloyd out.

When I first came here, all I received were glares of contempt and hatred.

Lloyd recalled the first time he came to possess this body. Everyone gave him the cold shoulder. It was so chilly and glacial, and beneath their superficial respects due to his noble status, there was contempt on their faces and gazes. Some even convulsed in shock and turned around when they saw Lloyd walk in their direction.

But not anymore.

The gazes of contempt were now replaced with gazes of admiration. The looks of disgust had transformed into that of welcome and admiration. This change was also manifested in Count Arcos and Countess Marbella, who chucked their gardening gadgets and rushed to his side.

“Lloyd!”

“My, are you all right?!”

Both of them were completely out of breath as they wrapped their arms around Lloyd. Their hands were caked with dirt that they failed to shake off on their way to him. Lloyd was grateful for that. He was overwhelmed with gratitude toward them for regarding him as their son and always warmly welcoming him with open arms. And he was more appreciative that their concerns preceded their warm welcome and joy to see him.

“Let’s see,” the countess said. “Are you well? Lloyd?”

The countess clapped over Lloyd’s cheeks with her hands. It looked like the Bone Dragon behind Lloyd was completely invisible in her field of vision.

Lloyd wondered if that was what mothers were like. Their children came first even in the presence of a giant and oppressive creature. The way she looked at Lloyd was filled with motherly concern.

“I heard about the news. It must have been terribly cold. My boy. Why did you have to get involved in such a dangerous endeavor?”

“Ahahaha,” laughed Lloyd awkwardly. “Wait, news of the frigid air leak spread all the way here?”

“Of course. Do you have any idea how shocked we were at the news?”

“Um, I am sorry.”

“No need for apologies.” She replied as she rubbed his cheeks. “Are you all right? Are you hurt?”

“Oh, that incident happened a long time ago. I am perfectly fine as you see.”

“Any aftereffects? Did you see your doctor?”

“Oh, yes. They said that I am fine.”

“What about the trial? Were you not scared?”

“Hahaha...”

“You shouldn’t have done something so dangerous.”

“Well, it just happened before I realized...”

Lloyd found himself letting out a chuckle. Mothers were the same. No matter what extraordinary feat their sons notched up, for example, riding the Bone Dragon, they were nothing but a mere child in the eyes of the mothers. This touched him.

Mother.

Suddenly, Lloyd's brain summoned his mother in South Korea. He felt that if she were alive and saw him now, she would be asking the same questions with the same look of concern on the countess's face. Touched, Lloyd grabbed the count and countess's hands, and he looked at the count, his eyes wet with tears.

"I am proud of you," Count Arcos encouraged as he patted Lloyd's shoulder. "Good job."

"Thank you."

Lloyd choked up once more. He then made a decision. He would protect them. He would work harder from now on as he wanted to be with them for as long as possible. With that resolution, he flashed a big smile as he held back his tears. Then he spoke the words he always yearned to say when he had a family.

"I am home..."

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Chapter 309: The Need for a Dam (1)

“Bibeong!”

Like any other day, Bibeong acted as an alarm and woke everyone in the peaceful Frontera fiefdom that sat at the eastern mountain range.

Farmers rubbed their eyes and got ready for the morning, and bulls drooled as they waited for the morning fodder. Hens that pecked on the ants in the backyard received insults over their incapacity to cuckoo-doodle-doo the heck of out every morning. Everyone was at peace. It was the start of yet another ordinary day. But as for Lloyd, who had returned to his own bed for the first time in a while...

Peaceful day, my ass!

As soon as Bibeong went off, Lloyd jumped out of his bed, threw on some clothes, and darted out of his room. He ran his hands through his disheveled hair on his way to the guest’s chamber and woke the Dragon King with his screeching singing. Afterward, he had breakfast with the count and countess before immediately jumping into work.

Duh. I don’t have any time to spare for rest!

Lloyd was completely serious. Now wasn’t the time to rest or laze around.

I busted my ass off to collect all the key materials needed for construction and even managed to sign a contract with the merpeople’s queen. So, it’s time to build the Jewel of Truth.

He had to stop the restoration of destiny from dooming them all. Lloyd had about two years left to do so. The mere thought of it made him antsy.

There’s more to do after building the Jewel of Truth. That’s just the means to find the answer for how to stop the restoration of destiny.

Lloyd would have to take action based on the answer he was given, which could require an immense amount of time and effort. As such, at this juncture, he had to put his nose to the grindstone.

“And so... You are climbing up a mountain this early in the morning to hurry the construction of the Jewel of Truth?” asked Javier.

“Yeah, why else? Then did you think I suddenly had found an affinity for hiking or something?”

Javier was forced to hike the eastern mountain range with Lloyd. His grouch made Lloyd smile.

Javier furrowed. “Yes, Master Lloyd. I wondered why you were hiking when you could have easily flown up to the summit with Sir Ggoming.”

“That did cross my mind,” replied Lloyd as he took another step up.

“Then why do you insist on climbing up the mountain yourself?”

“Ggoming’s sick.”

Javier looked at Lloyd.

“I’m not lying,” Lloyd replied as he jumped over a big rock. “Ppodong, Bangul, and Hamang. They’re all sick. You know how they’ve been dragged around lately without getting any time to rest.”

Lloyd’s smile turned bitter. What he just said was true. Last night, starting with Ppodong, everyone started to groan in pain, alongside developing a mild fever. They seemed to have muscle aches as they started to whine. It was a cold outbreak

“Well, that does make sense,” Javier seconded. “They’ve been kept on their toes until suddenly returning to the comfort of their home.”

“Yeah. That should be it. All the tension in their bodies must’ve been released when they got here,” agreed Lloyd.

“How about you, Master Lloyd? Are you okay?”

“Yeah, as you can see. I have a lot of work to do ahead of me.”

Of course. It wasn’t the time to loosen up just yet, so there was no reason for him to get sick. Javier’s gaze narrowed. “Then what is my role in your abrupt morning hike?”

“You still don’t know?” asked Lloyd genuinely as he stopped.

“No.” Javier stopped, too.

Lloyd shrugged. “I brought you with me for fun. Hiking alone is boring.”

Javier shot him a look.

“There it is again,” accused Lloyd. “You’re glaring at me. I’m doing all of this with your best interest in mind.”

“My best interest? How?”

“The air here is refreshing.” Lloyd inhaled as he spoke.

“So?” demanded Javier.

“Think about it. When we were in Seoul, you know, the place in that other dimension. The air there was horrifying. Remember?”

“Yes, it was.” Javier did remember it very well.

“That’s why I took you here to cleanse your lungs.”

“I would rather you stick to your first answer and say you were bored.”

“You see, I still meant I brought you with me because I was bored either way.”

“It’s not like I can give him a punch…” Javier mumbled.

Lloyd stopped dead in his tracks. “What was that?”

“Nothing.” Javier continued to move.

“I heard everything,” Lloyd said as he followed.

“Why are you listening to my genuine, inner thoughts without permission?”

“Your genuine, inner thoughts?” huffed Lloyd. “Shamelessly revealing your violent desires out in the open now, I see.”

“Everyone has their own sincere desires and hopes they keep to themselves.”

“Tsk. Whatever you say. Anyway, we’re here,” Lloyd announced. “Woah.”

As the two prattled, their destination came into view. They stepped over the last mound in front of them, and soon, the marvelous landscape of the mountain lake spanned in front of them. It was Lake Kapua, the place they once hiked to build the waterway and where Bibeong used to hibernate.

This is bringing back memories.

Recollections of the past rushed back to his mind while visiting the mountain after such a long time. However, he came today to do work. Lloyd tensed his eyes.

Surveying! Crackle!

[Scanning will begin.]

The terrains of the lake were scanned inside his head as soon as the familiar message popped up, each piece of information being translated into the design space. Of course, he had scanned this area before, but Lloyd decided to see if there were any changes made in the terrain.

This time, I have to also check the underwater terrains.

Lloyd removed his boots and shirts.

“I’m going to look around further into the lake. Sit tight and stay here. Don’t play around while you do.”

“Sit tight?” Javier retorted curiously.

Lloyd scoffed. “You should be surveying the ground while I’m busily working my butt off in the water. How else will you protect me?”

“Hmm, why do I feel that you are simply being mischievous because you can’t stand seeing me relax while you work?”

“No...” denied Lloyd. “Your accusation is false.”

“Noted. I will play hard as per your instruction.”

“Tsk. You sly man.”

“Speak for yourself, Master Lloyd.”

With that, Lloyd jumped into the lake. *Splash!*

To Lloyd’s relief, the lake was clear. He could see a fair distance ahead of him, even without any goggles.

Let’s see. Where should I build the Jewel of Truth?

Relying on his underwater breathing skill, Lloyd studied the bottom of the lake with a studious look on his face. There were several flat surfaces that seemed to be viable candidates.

The Jewel of Truth only operates under flowing water.

Just then, Lloyd recalled the conversation with the mermaid queen the day before. She notified him that the Jewel of Truth had to be constructed in a flowing body of water. Unless it was built under a sea, river, or lake, the jewel wouldn’t activate.

I confirmed this myself.

Based on what he learned, Lloyd activated his design skill on his bed the previous night and observed the Jewel of Truth in his virtual design space. The queen was right. Lloyd saw a cautionary warning in the design description: "Must be built under flowing water with a depth of at least 230 feet to properly activate."

The only body of water that meets those conditions is here. Lake Kapua.

The Prona River that cuts across the fiefdom wasn't deep enough. The water depth requirement could be met only in this lake. Lloyd's observant gaze grew more careful.

Let's see. The floor here is flat and stable... But the current is too rough and strong. Not here. That one... is good, but I'll need to do something about how unstable the ground is. Okay, taking all factors into account and—gotcha. This is the best spot.

One hour into the job, Lloyd finally discovered the best spot to build the Jewel of Truth.

Now, it's time to run a test.

Lloyd transferred the site's data into his virtual design space and overlayered it with data from the Jewel of Truth.

Thud! Twang! Boom! The Jewel of Truth was constructed in the simulation space, the final output standing tall on the very spot Lloyd had just selected.

Great. It's standing tall and also beautiful. The 230-foot water level requirement is met. The water current is gentle. The water level will rarely go below 230 feet unless a severe drought strikes. Okay, should I try activating it?

Curiosity aroused in Lloyd when the construction was finished in the simulation space. He wondered what it would be like when the Jewel of Truth was operated. He clicked on the "Virtual operation" button in the space.

[You are operating the Jewel of Truth in the simulation space.]

The moment the message appeared, the Jewel of Truth emitted a great shock wave. *Kaboom!*

An explosive shock wave was produced at the peak of the building and blasted across the surrounding area. Its vibration suddenly created a tidal wave that was 200 feet tall. It then charged at the speed of a bullet train toward the border of the waters until it hit and destroyed the natural dam Bibeong had built when he first created this lake. The tsunami then continued to travel down the mountain.

Fearlessly and recklessly, like a raging bull, it swept everything in its way, the valleys, rifts, and the entire mountain. Finally, it hurtled into the terraced rice fields and coal mines until it annihilated everything in the Frontera fiefdom with its destructive current.

What the heck?

His eyes widened in horror. He turned off the simulation. He clearly understood what he saw and what would happen if he activated the Jewel of Truth in Lake Kapua.

Wow. You've got to be kidding me.

Lloyd heaved an unwitting sigh. But he felt relieved at the same time.

It's a good thing I ran a simulation out of simple curiosity. If I didn't... Whew. I don't want to even think about it.

His body was covered in chills. He had regarded building the Jewel of Truth as the final step of the job. That was why he had carefully inspected the bottom of the lake as though he were performing land valuations. It never occurred to him that such an outrageous event would happen once he activated Jewel of Truth.

What should I do now?

He felt stuck. One glimpse at the simulation was enough for him to understand the destruction the Jewel of Truth would bring when it was put to use.

It's a smaller version of the Vajont Dam in Italy.

In 1963, a landslide above the Vajont Dam created a powerful wave that eventually developed into a tsunami that swept several villages behind the dam. It was a shocking event that resulted in thousands of casualties.

I build the Jewel of Truth here in this lake, and it's going to happen right here in my fiefdom. The wave I saw was unbelievably high. At that height, I won't be able to prevent the tidal wave from developing no matter where I build the Jewel of Truth in this lake.

This only meant one thing.

This lake won't work.

Lloyd heaved a sigh. This time, it was heavier than before. Lloyd was flustered.

Tsk. What should I do? The Prona River is too shallow. And building a reservoir won't do since there will be no water current. Should I search for lakes in other regions? But I don't want to do that since I signed a contract to construct the building in my fiefdom. And besides, I hate the thought of putting this precious structure on top of someone else's land.

Lloyd thought building it in the Mermaid Kingdom was a hundred times better than doing so. Lloyd racked his brain, and he only sunk deeper into thought as he went down the mountain with Javier.

What should I do?

The tidal wave. This was an unexpected stumbling block. Even when he was back at the manor, after sending Javier away, resting his back against the bed as he stared at the opposite wall, Lloyd continued to think.

Build a wall in the lake that would stop the waves? Will it prevent any damage? No. For that to work, the wall has to be extremely high and sturdy. And besides, it's impossible to put up a wall on just one side. It has to be erected along the corners of the lake.

Lake Kapua was a mountain lake that was as large as Lake Chuncheon in South Korea. To enclose the lake, he would have to build a wall that was several miles long, even for just a portion of it.

It's ridiculous. Just imagine building a wall that's several miles long to stop a 200-foot-tall wave. I can't begin to imagine how thick it will need to be to withstand the impact of such a wave.

It was a terribly unrealistic and large-scale project. Moreover, it was even less likely that the walls could be maintained over time.

This isn't a viable method. Not a chance.

Lloyd crossed out the method in his head. Even after that, Lloyd continued to rack his brain. Past lunchtime and afternoon, the sun dipped down as it set the sky on fire. Then Lloyd heard someone knocking on his room. It was Emily. *Tap tap tap.*

"Master Lloyd, please excuse me. It's Emily," she said from the other side of the door.

"Yeah, what's going on?" Lloyd said aloud.

"I'm here to collect your laundry. May I come in?"

"Sure, come on in."

As soon as he permitted, the door opened and revealed a grinning Emily. "Good afternoon, Master Lloyd. Please excuse me for a second."

"Sure, no problem."

Lloyd remained seated against the bed as he stared at Emily get to work. Of course, he was absolutely engrossed in the Jewel of Truth situation. But his

gaze, though blank, must have affected Emily, for a blush appeared on her cheeks as she collected his laundry. Slightly flustered, she started to stammer.

“Um, I will bring them back all nice and neat. These shirts. Your pants, too.”

“Yes, thank you,” replied Lloyd blankly.

“I actually have become better at washing clothes.” She twisted her body as if she was overcome with embarrassment. Her eyes were fixed on the ground. “A long time ago, I just scrubbed the laundry as best as I could before rinsing them off. Completely unaware of what the others were doing, especially the other servants situated higher up the stream.”

“Higher up the stream. Other servants?” Lloyd asked.

“Yes,” Emily said shyly as she grinned. It looked like she was glad to see Lloyd respond to her. “The thing was, no matter how hard I washed the clothes, it was all pointless if those up the stream released the lye into the water at a different time than me.”

“Hmm. That makes sense. After all, you’ll have to wash the clothes all over again if the detergent, no, lye, gets into what you just washed.”

“Yes, that’s right,” she affirmed, her voice sounding more cheerful. “So, these days, I’ve learned to sync with the others. I can now wash the shirts faster and better. It’s all because I keep an eye on the water coming down from upstream.”

“Keep an eye on the water coming down from upstream, you say... You’re right. Up... Hm? Hold on right there.”

Lloyd stopped. He was just blankly repeating what Emily said when something, an epiphany, struck his mind. An idea started to circulate in his head.

Upstream water. Higher. Flowing. Wait, if that’s the case... Downstream?

Before he knew it, Lloyd was already standing up. Then he began to trudge around the room, nibbling his underlip, developing the idea in his head. He inspected, studied, measured, and made predictions until an answer came to him.

“This is it... Thank you!” exclaimed Lloyd triumphantly.

“Excuse me? Young master?”

Overcome with joy, Lloyd grabbed Emily’s hand and jumped up and down several times. Afterward, he rushed out of the room before Emily could even make sense of what was happening. He darted along the corridor, jumped down the stairs, and entered the dining room, wherein he found Count Arcos about to eat dinner.

At the sight of him, Lloyd blurted, “Um, I am thinking of building a gravity dam downstream of the Prona River.”

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Chapter 310: The Need for a Dam (2)

“Um, I am thinking of building a gravity dam downstream of the Prona River.”

“Hmm?”

Count Arcos was about to take a spoonful of his soup when his son abruptly emerged and made an equally abrupt suggestion. But he wasn’t taken aback. Instead, he offered Lloyd a seat first.

“Son, you must be here because you have something to say. Am I right?”

“Oh, yes, you are.”

“Then take a seat first.” Count Arcos could tell from the look on Lloyd’s face that his son came to make a slightly over-the-top request. But he wasn’t in the least bit worried.

I can trust him.

Lloyd had proved his diligence countless times up to this point. He would undoubtedly continue to do so throughout the future as well. But more than that, Lloyd was his son, the count thought. He was ready to accept whatever favor his son would request of him.

“Build a dam downstream of the river?” asked Count Arcos. “A gravity dam? I have never heard of such a thing.”

“I am sure you haven’t,” acknowledged Lloyd.

“Before that,” the count went on. “Have you eaten dinner?”

“Not yet,” Lloyd replied.

“Care to join us? We can talk while eating.”

“Yes, thank you.” Seated across from the count, Lloyd stared at the dishes the servants prepared for him as he organized his thoughts in his head. He held his fork and started, “Um, first... I believe I have confused you by barging in on you like this. I know this all sounds new to you, but there’s something grave I must tell you today.”

“We are your mother and father. Do not worry. Do speak.”

Count Arcos smiled gently. Countess Marbella did the same. This soothing atmosphere relieved Lloyd, who was about to reveal the need for the dam. That, however, was only possible with talking about the Jewel of Truth, which was equally impossible with mentioning the restoration of destiny. This conversation, no doubt, was burdensome to Lloyd.

That is why their reactions comforted Lloyd. Their composure and warmth assured him that all of his requests would be accepted, and they would be there to hold his hands during times of trouble. Lloyd felt encouraged and touched, and he was able to bring up the subject more comfortably.

“Okay,” revealed Lloyd. “So, to tell you the reason behind this, everyone here, including me, will be gone in five years.”

“What?” The count’s eyes widened in surprise.

Lloyd continued to speak.

“It is the truth,” emphasized Lloyd, “A giant inescapable catastrophe is heading in our direction. Since about a year ago, I have had the same nightmare every night wherein everyone dies. I simply regarded it as a nightmare and nothing more at first. One day, however, Dragon King Verkis advised me that it wasn’t a simple nightmare. It is really the future that is ahead of us.”

Lloyd couldn’t tell the count and countess about the Ending Spoiler and the restoration of destiny as they were. So, he had to come up with this story of his nightmares.

“I was able to confirm that it wasn’t just a dream,” Lloyd went on to speak, giving no time for them to ask questions. “Thanks to the Dragon King’s advice. I asked him what I should do to stop the arrival of such a dreadful future. Then he told me.”

“What did he say?” asked Count Arcos, his voice breaking.

“That the future I saw was a wretched disaster I cannot easily change. Even if I could foresee what would happen and when, it would be useless to try to prevent the events from happening. In any case, another accident would occur at another time in some other way. Our impending doom would be inevitable.”

“That is terribly wretched. And so?”

“I asked him again. Is there any other way to stop these nightmares from happening? Then he enlightened me with the sole solution to this disaster.”

Lloyd stopped there and stared at both. The two of them were intently listening to him with forks in their hands and completely forgot about their food. This made Lloyd feel more confident.

Okay. They’re buying my words.

It looked like the diligence he had shown up to this point and the Dragon King’s authority worked together to convince them that what he was saying was true. It was a relief.

Breaking the grave ambiance hanging at the dinner table, Lloyd said, “The Dragon King told me that I need to find and build the Jewel of Truth.”

“The Jewel of Truth...?”

“That’s right.” Lloyd nodded. This was the part he didn’t need to fabricate in his story. Now that the topic of their discussion moved to the Jewel of Truth, he could speak to them without including any lies.

“He said that the Jewel of Truth was the most powerful treasure of the mythical age. The Dragon King Verkis said that it was the building that

revealed the wisest solutions to any problems that it was asked. The Dragon King Verkis said that all I had to do was find this treasure and ask for a solution to stop the impending disaster. Who told me that? Dragon King Verkis."

"I-I see," replied Count Arcos, slightly dazed by the several mentions of the Dragon King. "The Dragon King is truly a kind and wise man."

"Yes, and that is actually the reason why I made the trip to Cremo."

Count Arcos set his utensils down. "To find the Jewel of Truth? Wait, are all the rocks the Bone Dragon brought..."

"Yes, you are right. They are the key construction materials required to build the Jewel of Truth. I found and brought them here."

"I see. It must have been a lot of work."

"Haha, it wasn't much."

"Please. It couldn't have been easy."

The count and the countess looked at him with pity in their gazes. To their reaction, Lloyd could only put on an embarrassed smile. It looked like they were more bothered by the hardships Lloyd had gone through rather than the incoming disaster.

Haha... Their reaction is so unexpected. How touching...

However, this wasn't the time to indulge in mushiness. It was the time to objectively go over the matter at hand. Pulling himself together, Lloyd shared the requirements for building the Jewel of Truth and the unexpected and disastrous stumbling block he encountered on the way.

"So," went on Lloyd. "I concluded that building a dam was the best solution that meets the construction requirements and saves our fiefdom from the most amount of water damage at the same time."

“Are you saying since the tsunami is unavoidable anyway, it is best to make it happen downstream?”

“Yes. That is exactly what I mean.” What the count was the crux of the matter. “Since the downstream of the Prona River touches no fiefdom. No one lives around there. So, the tidal wave will not harm anyone.”

“I understand your words. You must have rushed down here after finally coming up with this solution just now.”

“Yes, I did.”

“Ha, my dear Lloyd.” Count Arcos called, sighing heavily.

“Yes?”

“Next time,” Count Arcos said woefully, “When you encounter a problem that worries you this much, do talk to me about it. I am your father. It must be stressful to think and contemplate all by yourself every time.”

“Um, that’s—”

“I know even if you do not say it out loud,” Count Arcos put in. “You must have your reasons for why you could not disclose it to us. That is why you pretended to be okay when you were secretly worried. But next time, do give us a chance. A chance to be with you during your difficult moments.”

Lloyd cleared his throat. “Yes... I will. Then, as for the dam construction-”

“It must be done. No doubt about that. How could I reject your request after all the trouble you went through to reach this conclusion?”

“Thank you...!”

He did it. Lloyd succeeded in explaining the restoration of destiny and the need for the jewel construction. He got the permission from Count Arcos, the owner of the fiefdom. Lloyd inwardly clenched his fists.

Haah. That’s one more problem out of my way.

Lloyd expected getting approval for the dam construction to be an easy task. The hard part would be figuring out a good explanation for the restoration of destiny and the Jewel of Truth. Now that it was all over, he felt as if he finished one big assignment at school. The following day, he started the construction project.

This is the perfect spot for the dam.

Lloyd was able to find a suitable spot after observing the downstream of the Prona River on the northern border of his fiefdom.

The limestone valley touching both river sides narrows drastically. The slope for the flexure layer sufficiently cuts down as well. And the lower part of the river, that peak over there. It's supporting the pressure coming from the ground like a pair of training wheels on a child's bike.

The more Lloyd looked at it, the more perfect it was. This spot provided the most stability out of all the terrains.

To my luck, I know a dam on earth that was built somewhere with a similar terrain. The Tibi Dam was built in Alicante, Spain.

Lloyd recalled how he had researched the place back in college. The information he looked over then started to come back to him in bits and pieces.

The dam was constructed using only medieval technologies. The construction started in 1579 and was completed after fifteen years in 1594.

Of course, compared to the modern one, its size wasn't anything impressive. It was only 141 feet tall, and the radius of its arch was 351 feet.

But it's the perfect structure for me to reference since I can't rely on modern technology.

For this, Lloyd would have to rely on Javier, the fantastical creatures, the Engineering Corps, and the Skeleton Corps again. He would need to resort to all sorts of tricks in place of what modern technology had to offer. This

technological limitation was exactly why Lloyd found medieval architecture to be a more useful reference for him than other modern structures. A case in point was this dam.

The terrain here is similar. So a gravity arch dam like the Tibi Dam should be a good fit for this project.

Lloyd believed that he could build a safe and sturdy dam if he combined the gravity dam that resisted water pressure by using its own weight, much like tanks in video games, with an arch structure to give it more stability.

The limestone that's necessary for dam construction is also plentiful in this area.

This environment couldn't be any more perfect for the construction in many ways. Convinced, Lloyd dutifully surveyed the terrain to determine the location to put the dam. The amount of water the dam would hold. The geographical range of the areas that would be submerged in water due to the dam. The location for the Jewel of Truth. The size and power of the wave. The impact of the wave on the dam. Details of the device that would reduce the impact of it. He considered all the information he collected, possible scenarios, and any other variables he could. For this, he actively used the simulation option in his survey skill.

Lloyd experimented, measured, considered, edited, and designed. He reviewed, revised, and then repeated this entire process. At times, he would scratch his head and rub his tired eyes while he did.

Some nights, after he put Javier to sleep, Lloyd went back to his room and worked through the night, the toil eventually bursting his nose. In the morning, Emily would find his blood-stained shirts and rush to the count and countess to tell on him. Countess Marbella became so worried that she prepared all the healthy meals she knew of to feed her son. Fueled by gratitude, Lloyd would then push himself to review his design once again. He engrossed himself in drawing up a design, making every minute and second count in his day. Ten days, fifteen days, and thirty days passed. And at last, Lloyd finished the design for the dam and the Jewel of Truth.

Haah. That took a while and was quite exhausting.

Lloyd breathed out, feeling sick to his stomach. Even though he was backed by several skills, designing was particularly strenuous on this occasion as there were too many factors to take into account.

But, oh well, like if it wasn't hard any other times.

Lloyd chuckled at the thought. Right. There never was a time when coming up with a design was easy across all of the projects he had done so far.

So, I should work hard this time too. Now that the design is finished. Hmm... Looks like the construction can start in fifteen days, considering the time it'll take to set up the construction schedule and acquire the necessary materials and people.

Lloyd crinkled his nose. Thanks to his obsessive hard work for the past month, there were only a few small preparations left to do before the actual construction could begin.

Time freeze. I need to use the skill again for this project.

The dam construction would require an extraordinary amount of time. But it wouldn't be as much as the Tibi Dam, which took fifteen years to complete. But still, even if he mobilized the fantastical creatures and Draggy, the construction would take a fair amount of time to do.

So, Time Freeze is a must for this construction. I need to save time when I can. But to do that... I'll have to inform everyone about it...

Lloyd believed he had to give everyone in the fiefdom a heads-up that there was no need to panic when the world froze outside their fiefdom as it was not the work of an evil magician. He jumped into action right away.

Oh well. This is life.

The night Lloyd finished the design, he abruptly announced at the dinner table, "I can stop time!"

The outburst shocked Count and Countess Frontera, who thought to themselves that their son must have gone through a lot lately to be this deluded.

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